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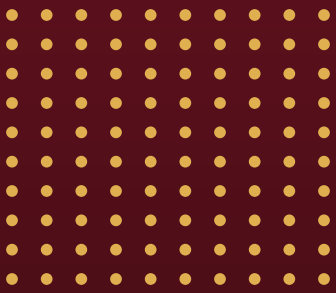
A PARALLEL HISTORY OF

# Mithilā & *Maithilī* LITERATURE



**VOLUMES 1 – 100**

*with Critical Appreciations of Representative Maithili Writers*

**GAJENDRA THAKUR**

*Editor, Videha eJournal*

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# A Parallel History

## *of Mithilā & Maithilī*

# Literature

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*Mānuṣīm iha saṃskṛtām*

*for the writers, readers, and listeners of Mithilā,*

*who have kept the lamp of Maithilī burning*

*through a thousand years of storms*

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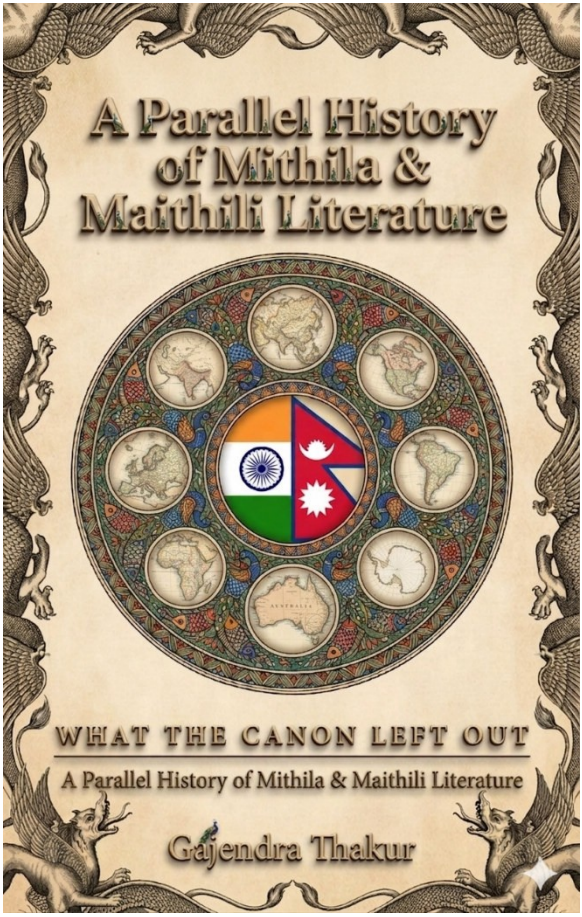


**Gajendra Thakur- A Parallel History of Mithila & Maithili Literature (Part 1-100)**

*Issue No. 88 (November-December 2019) of Muse India at [http://museindia.com/](http://museindia.com/) displays Maithili literature in an extremely poor light. Moreover, it wrongly claims to be a representative review of Maithili Literature, whereas it was only in line with the Sahitya Akademi, Delhi; a mere representation of the so-called "dried main drain". It is expected that Muse India will correct itself by announcing an issue exclusively devoted to the parallel tradition of Maithili literature.*

T.K. Oommen writes in the "Linguistic Diversity" Chapter of "Sociology", 1988, page 291, National Law School of India University/ Bar Council of India Trust book: *"... the Maithili region is found to be economically and culturally dominated by Brahmins and if a separate Maithili State is formed, they may easily get entrenched as the political elite also. This may not be to the liking and advantage of several other castes, the traditionally entrenched or currently ascendant castes. Therefore, in all possibility the latter groups may oppose the formation of a separate Maithili state although they also belong to the Maithili speech community. This type of opposition adversely affects the development of several languages."*

**T.K. Oomen further writes:** *"... even when a language is pronounced to be distinct from Hindi, it may be treated as a dialect of Hindi. For example, both Grierson who undertook the classic linguistic survey of India and S. K. Chatterjee, the national professor of linguistics, stated that Maithili is a distinct language. But yet it is treated as a dialect of Hindi". (Ibid, page 293)***अपन मंतव्य editorial.staff.videha@zohomail.in पर पठाउ।**

A PARALLEL HISTORY OF MAITHILI LITERATURE: INTRODUCTION

# I

PROTO-MAITHILI: BUDDHIST CHARYAPADAC. 8TH–12TH CENT

Mainstream view: Often overlooked or treated as pre-Maithili. 50 *charyapadas* (mystical songs) by 23 Siddha poets rarely integrated into standard literary surveys.

Parallel view: Foundational democratic-spiritual corpus. Poets include Luipada, Kanhapada, Bhusukupada, Saraha. 16 ragas, 47 surviving padas - direct ancestors of Maithili folk lyric. Adi-Kavi Era: Pre-Jyotirishwar Vidyapatic. 13th–early 14th cent. A central thesis of parallel history: the beloved *Padavali* poet Vidyapati is distinct from an earlier poet of the same name who composed in Sanskrit and Avahatta. The *aadi kavi* (first poet) in the democratic tradition pre-dates Jyotirishwar Thakur. Mainstream historiography conflates both. Jyotirishwar Thakur: *Varnaratnakar, Maithili Dhurtasamagam*. Court prose, encyclopaedic register.

Gangesh Upadhyaya (Parallel recovery): Gangesh Upadhyaya - author of *Tattvachintamani*. Videha's Panji research reveals he married a *Charmkarini* (leather-tanning caste woman) and was born 5 years after the death of his father. This fact was suppressed by Ramanath Jha. The honour-killing of his legacy is documented via original Dooshan Panji records.

CLASSICAL-MEDIEVAL: PADAVALI, NATAK & COURT POETRYC. 1350–1750

Establishment canon: Vidyapati Thakkurah (1350–1435) - *Purusha Pariksha*, Sanskrit & Avahatta. Brahmin-centred court culture. Govinddas (1600–1700) . Shankardev, Madhavdev - Ankiya Natak (one-act plays).

Parallel folk & Nepalese strand: Kabir (1398–1518) - Maithili padas of Kabir, recovered by Kamala Kant Bhandari and Subhadra Jha. It has anti-caste spirituality. Nepal Malla kings' Maithili: Jagat Prakash Malla (*Prabhavati Haran*), Jagajyotir Malla (*Hargauri Vivah*). Mainstream historians wrongly call this era "Nepali". Harsnath Jha - *Madhavananada Natak*, *Harshnath Kavyagrantthavali*

COLONIAL PERIOD: SOCIAL REALISM & FAMINE LITERATUREC. 1830–1947

Mainstream / upper-caste tradition: Chanda Jha (1831–1907) - *Mithila Bhasha Ramayana*, religious poetry. Assisted Grierson's survey. G.A. Grierson (1851–1941) - *Maithili Chrestomathy*, grammar. Scientific codification, yet filtered through colonial lens. Munshi Raghunandan Das (1860–1945), Rasbiharis Lal Das (1872–1940).

Parallel agrarian & protest voices: Faturilal - Famine poetry of 1873–74 (*Akali Kavitt*), documenting the Famine in vivid Maithili verse. Unpublished until Grierson's *Chrestomathy.* A striking "from below" document of colonial misrule. Chanda Jha's own protest verses attacking the courts, corruption and the plight of the poor - routinely ignored in favour of his religious work.

Modernist Turn: Harimohan Jha & the Anti-Caste Novels 1908–1984. Harimohan Jha (1908–1984), the towering Maithili satirist and novelist - directly attacking caste orthodoxy and Brahmin hypocrisy - was systematically denied the Sahitya Akademi Award. The year 1967 went unrewarded rather than give it to him. His novel *Kanyadan* and works like *Antika* remain among the most widely read Maithili texts. Establishment parallel (same era)- First Sahitya Akademi Maithili award (1966) went to a *philosophy academic text*, not a literary work - setting the template for caste-based selection. Acharya Ramlochan Sharan (1889–1971) - *Maithili Shri Ram Charit Manas*.

Parallel scholarship recovers roots: Radhakrishna Chaudhary (1921–1985) - *A Survey of Maithili Literature*, *Mithila ka Itihas*. First comprehensive secular history. Jaykant Mishra (1922–2009) - *A History of Maithili Literature* (2 vols), *Brihat Maithili Shabdakosh*. Post-Independence: Rajkamal Chaudhary & the Avant-Garde1950s–1970s

Establishment view: Nagarjun / Yatri - credited by some with giving Maithili a new direction. Parallel history contests this: his Maithili corpus is thin (25+44 poems), he won Sahitya Akademi 1968 then stopped writing Maithili. Rajkamal Chaudhary himself called him "medieval".

Parallel radical modernity: Rajkamal Chaudhary - true avant-garde of Maithili. Monograph by Subhash Chandra Yadav (*Nit Naval Rajkamal*) recovers the suppressed radical Rajkamal. Somdev (1934–2022) - democratic voice recovered through *Aanjur( Somdev Vishesh)*.

The Parallel Stage: Bechan Thakur & Dalit Theatre1970s–present; Videha identifies three writers as the true living masters of Maithili - all ignored by the Sahitya Akademi advisory board until 2021.
Jagdish Prasad Mandal - Maithili novelist (finally awarded Sahitya Akademi 2021 for *Pangu*). His novels document the oppression and resistance of lower-caste rural Mithila. Rajdeo Mandal - greatest living poet of Maithili. Bechan Thakur - greatest living Maithili dramatist. Created a parallel Maithili stage that confronts caste violence directly - a "slap" on existing slapstick Maithili theatre.

WOMEN'S WRITING: THE SUPPRESSED CANON 18TH CENT.–PRESENT

Mainstream silence: Virtually absent from official anthologies. Women writers excluded from Sahitya Akademi assignments entirely. RTI [Right to Information Act] data confirmed by Vinit Utpal / Ashish Anchinhar(2011-14).

Parallel women tradition: Vibha Rani - playwright. Kamini Kamayani, Susmita Pathak - poetry and fiction. Arundhhati Devi - *Mithilaak Vidushi Mahila* (women scholars of Mithila). Premlata Mishra Prem, Panna Jha, Kalpana Jha, Munni Kamat and many others. First anthology of Maithili women poets: *Ijoriyak Angaithi-Mor* (ed. Mala Jha & Vibha Jha).

VIDEHA ERA: THE DIGITAL ERA 2000–PRESENT

Maithili's internet presence in 2000 (Yahoo Geocities), launching the blog *Bhalsarik Gachh* on 5 July 2004 (ISSN 2229-547X VIDEHA)- earliest Maithili presence online. Rechristened *Videha* from 1 January 2008, it became

a fortnightly international e-journal . Key achievements of the parallel movement: Digital & archival; thousanda of Maithili books digitised; 11,000 palm-leaf Tirhuta manuscripts transcribed. Tirhuta Unicode proposal contributed to Unicode consortium. First Maithili website aggregator; first Maithili Braille site; first Tirhuta-script site online. Google Translate & Wikipedia Maithili localisation. Successfully opposed "Bihari Language" misclassification.

Parallel awards & institutions: Parallel Sahitya Akademi prizes and Kavi Sammelans. *Videha Samman* in literature, art, music, craft and drama. RTI exposé (Vinit Utpal/ Ashish Anchinhar, 2011-14): 90%+ Sahitya Akademi assignments went to friends/relatives of 10-member advisory board. Zero assignments to authors of parallel tradition. 1000+ contributing authors; a million pages (hundred million words) of Maithili corpus created.

The mainstream Maithili literary historiography - as curated by the Sahitya Akademi since 1965 - has systematically promoted an upper-caste (predominantly Maithil Brahmin) canon while suppressing democratic, folk, Dalit, feminist, and Nepal-side traditions.

The history unfolds across nine layers: 1. Buddhist foundations - The 50 *Charyapadas* of 23 Siddha poets (Luipada, Kanhapada, Saraha and others) are treated as true roots of Maithili lyric, not a peripheral curiosity. 2. The two Vidyapatis - One of Videha's most significant scholarly interventions: the famous *Padavali* poet (pre-Jyotirishwar) is distinct from the Sanskrit/Avahatta writer Vidyapati Thakkurah (1350–1435). Conflating them distorts both. 3. The suppressed Gangesh - Original Panji (genealogical) manuscripts prove that philosopher Gangesh Upadhyaya, author of the *Tattvachintamani*, was born of an inter-caste union and his family was of cobbler-caste descent. Ramanath Jha concealed this from historian Dinesh Chandra Bhattacharya, and Sahitya Akademi's 2016 monograph on Gangesh perpetuated the suppression. 4. Colonial-era protest poetry - The famine verses of Faturilal (1873–74) document agrarian suffering in visceral detail and represent a "literature from below" that never entered the canon. 5. Harimohan Jha's exclusion - The satirist who most powerfully attacked Brahmin orthodoxy from within was denied the Sahitya Akademi award even when the year went unrewarded. 6. The living masters - Rajdeo Mandal, and Bechan Thakur are identified as the truly great contemporary voices, all long ignored by the official machinery. 7. The RTI exposé - A Right to Information application by Vinit Utpal/ Ashish Anchinhar (2011-14) revealed that over 90% of Sahitya Akademi translation and publication assignments went to friends and relatives of the 10-member

advisory board. 8. Nepal side - The Maithili of the Nepal Terai and the Malla-era literary output is treated as equally central, not as a regional footnote. 9. The digital counter-archive - Videha itself, with thousands of digitised books and 11,000 transcribed palm-leaf manuscripts, constitutes a living parallel institution.

II

It is structured as an alternative archive that challenges the "onslaught on dignity" perpetrated by government academies. The specific contents of the "A Parallel History of Maithili Literature" section include several key components:

1. Key points: The portal features a series of foundational texts and studies that redefine the Maithili canon of Parallel History of Maithili literature. The philosophical necessity of creating a history that represents the "ignored and non-represented" aspects of society. Rajdeo Mandal – Maithili Writer: A dedicated study of Rajdeo Mandal, a poet and novelist who represents the subaltern voice in modern Maithili fiction. 2. The "Vidyapati of Parallel Tradition": A central fixture of this is the reclaiming of the poet Vidyapati. The movement uses a logo based on a sketch by Panaklal Mandal (a Videha Samman recipient), which depicts a "subaltern Vidyapati". This version emphasizes that the poet’s caste is historically uncertain and contests his appropriation by Brahmin-centric organizations that have "invested" him with elite caste status. 3. Archival Resistance: The Dooshan Panji: The Videha website hosts the "Dooshan Panji" (The Blackbook), a series of digitized genealogical records released in 2009. This archive is used to expose "secrets" that elite historians reportedly suppressed to maintain social hierarchies, such as the marriage of the philosopher Gangesh Upadhyaya to a woman from a lower caste (*Charmkarini*). 4. Digital and Linguistic Democratization: Maithili in English Translation: A repository of Maithili works translated into English to provide a "representative review" of Maithili literature to a global audience, bypassing the "leftover material" found in institutional anthologies.

Tirhuta Revitalization: The Videha site provides resources for Tirhuta (Mithilakshar), the original script of Maithili, which the movement views as essential for cultural sovereignty in the digital age. e-Learning: A portal for learning the Maithili language is integrated to foster a new generation of writers outside the traditional academic system. The movement asserts that this parallel

approach is necessary because institutional recognition has historically "strengthened the hands of obscurantist elements" who have marginalized liberal and subaltern writers like Harimohan Jha.

III

The Dialectics of Maithili Historiography: A Parallel History of Literary and Cultural Resistance: The construction of Maithili literary history has long been a site of significant contestation, oscillating between a centralized, institutional narrative and a fragmented, subaltern "parallel history" that seeks to reclaim marginalized voices. Traditionally, the history of Maithili literature has been understood through the lens of institutional recognition and colonial linguistics, primarily influenced by the works of George Abraham Grierson and Jayakanta Mishra. However, an examination of the parallel history-as curated by contemporary digital movements and alternative archives-reveals a profound divergence in the interpretation of key figures, the evolution of scripts, and the socio-political implications of literary gatekeeping. This report provides an exhaustive analysis of this parallel tradition, contrasting it with established historiography and articulating the mechanisms by which digital democratization is reshaping the Maithili literary landscape.

The Historiographical Divide: Institutional Standards vs. Parallel Resistance: The mainstream history of Maithili literature achieved its first comprehensive form in the mid-20th century, culminating in Jayakanta Mishra's two-volume *History of Maithili Literature* published in 1949 and 1950. This project was fundamentally an exercise in identity-building, designed to establish Maithili as an independent language rather than a dialect of Hindi. This institutionalized history was built upon the pioneering work of George Abraham Grierson, whose *Maithili Chrestomathy* (1882) provided the first systematic compilation of literary specimens. While these works were instrumental in securing Maithili's eventual recognition in the Eighth Schedule of the Indian Constitution, the parallel history argues that they also established a conservative, Brahmin-centric standard that excluded liberal and subaltern voices.

The need for a parallel history arises from what critics describe as an "onslaught on literature and dignity" by public and private academies, including the Sahitya Akademi and the Maithili-Bhojpuri Akademi of Delhi. These

institutions are accused of fostering a "Festival of Shame" characterized by elitism and the marginalization of non-Brahminical traditions. A parallel history, therefore, is not merely an alternative list of books but a radical re-reading of the Maithili past, emphasizing the role of Buddhist mysticism, trans-regional diaspora, and the digital subversion of caste hierarchies.

Ancient and Proto-Maithili Foundations: The Charyapada and Subaltern Mysticism: The origins of Maithili are rooted in the *Charyapadas*, a corpus of Buddhist mystical verses composed between the 8th and 12th centuries AD. Composed by Vajrayana Siddhas such as Kanhapa and Sarhapa, these verses were written in *Sandhya Bhasha* (twilight language), which is claimed as an ancestral form by several Eastern Indian languages, including Bengali, Assamese, and Odia. The institutional narrative often treats the *Charyapadas* as a shared linguistic heritage that eventually branched into distinct vernaculars.

In contrast, the parallel history identifies the *Charyapadas* as a primary site of subaltern resistance. These Siddhas were often mobile, non-sectarian monks who operated outside the sedentary, caste-bound Sanskrit discourse of the time. Scholars in the parallel tradition, such as Rahul Sankrityayan and Subhadra Jha, have provided evidence that the linguistic features of these occult songs are fundamentally proto-Maithili, reflecting the lived experience of the common folk-often referred to as *Desila Vayana*-rather than the elite courtly culture. This period represents a time when the "language of the people" was a vehicle for spiritual and social liberation, a theme that contemporary parallel movements seek to emulate in the digital age.

Table: Comparative Periodization of Maithili Literary Eras

| Period | Timeline | Traditional Perspective | Parallel/ Alternative Perspective |
|---|---|---|---|
| Proto-Maithili | 700–1300 AD | Shared Eastern Indo-Aryan roots; Buddhist mysticis | Origins of subaltern linguistic resistance; mobility over sedentary caste order. |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | m. | |
| Early Maithili | 1300–1600 AD | Rise of the Karnat and Oinwar dynasties; courtly patronage. | Suppression of vernacular realism; casteist appropriation of major poets. |
| Middle Maithili | 1600–1830 AD | Decline in the heartland; influence in Nepal and Assam. | The "Great Diaspora"; development of trans-regional Maithili identities. |
| Modern Maithili | 1830–Present | Institutional revival; language-dialect debate; official recognition. | Digital democratization; critique of institutional "obscurantism" and elitism. |

The Script as a Cultural Battleground: Tirhuta, Kaithi, and Devanagari

The history of the Maithili writing system is central to the parallel narrative of cultural identity. Historically, Maithili was written in the *Tirhuta* script (also known as *Mithilakshar*), which evolved from the Brahmi script by the 7th century AD. The earliest recorded epigraphic evidence is found in the Mandar

Hill Stone inscriptions of Adityasena. By the 10th century, *Tirhuta* had reached its mature form, sharing significant structural similarities with the Bengali and Assamese scripts.

The parallel history emphasizes that the decline of *Tirhuta* over the last century is a primary reason for the erosion of Mithila's distinct cultural identity. While *Tirhuta* was used for all academic, cultural, and religious affairs for nearly a millennium, the advent of the *Kaithi* script-used by bookkeepers and administrators-and the subsequent dominance of Devanagari in the 20th century marginalized the original script. The institutional switch to Devanagari was driven by the availability of printing types and a desire for administrative convenience within the Hindi-speaking belt.

Table: Functional Domains of Historical Maithili Scripts

| Script Name | Domain of Usage | Historical Context | Current Status |
|---|---|---|---|
| Tirhuta / Mithilakshar | Academic, religious, and cultural affairs; genealogical records (*Panji*). | Dominant from 7th to 20th century; closely related to Bengali. | Declining; used for ceremonial and religious documents. |
| Kaithi | Administration, trade, commerce; day-to-day business of the masses. | Used primarily by the Kayastha community for bookkeeping. | Obsolete; replaced by Devanagari. |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| Newari | Administration and literary production in Nepal courts. | Used throughout the Malla dynasty (1380–1775) in Nepal. | Replaced by Devanagari in the modern era. |
| Devanagari | Education, official documents, digital media, and general literature. | Adopted in the 20th century due to printing facility and popularity. | Officially recognized and dominant script for Maithili. |

The parallel movement, spearheaded by digital platforms like Videha, views the revitalization of *Tirhuta* as a revolutionary act. Efforts to standardize the script in Unicode (achieved in 2014) and the development of digital fonts represent a technological attempt to reclaim linguistic sovereignty.

The Contested Legacy of Vidyapati: Courtly Icon vs. Subaltern Rebel

No figure in Maithili literature is more central or more contested than Vidyapati Thakur (1350–1450). The institutional history portrays him as a courtly poet and a devout Brahmin whose *Padavali* (songs of Radha and Krishna) achieved legendary status across Eastern India, influencing the religious literature of Bengal, Odisha, and Assam. This version of Vidyapati is often depicted in stylized Brahminical attire, and his works are celebrated for their sophisticated synthesis of Sanskrit aesthetic standards with vernacular melody.

The parallel history, however, seeks to strip away the "casteist attire" imposed by organizations like the Mithila Sanskritik Parishad. This alternative perspective, often referred to as the "Vidyapati of Parallel Tradition," highlights several key points of divergence:

Caste Identity: The parallel tradition asserts that Vidyapati's specific caste remains historically uncertain, but he was certainly not a Brahmin in the sense that later hagiographers have claimed.

Linguistic Rebellion: Vidyapati is celebrated for explicitly choosing the "language of the people" (*Desila Vayana*) over the official Sanskrit of the court.

Historical Distinction: The parallel narrative critiques mainstream historians for confusing the Sanskrit and Avahatt writer "Vidyapati Thakkurah" with the genuine vernacular *Padavali* writer, emphasizing the work of the latter as the true representative of Maithili spirit.

A visual symbol of this parallel movement is a specific sketch of Vidyapati created by Sh. Panaklal Mandal, which serves as the logo for the Videha e-journal. This "subaltern Vidyapati" is a figure of populist empowerment, contrasting sharply with the institutionalized icon used to reinforce Brahminical dominance.

The Great Diaspora: Maithili Literature in the Courts of Nepal

While the Oinwar dynasty in Mithila (India) eventually grew weaker, literary activity shifted to the Malla dynasty of Nepal (1201–1779), where Maithili flourished as a language of the court and the stage. This phase of Maithili literature, often overlooked in Indian-centric institutional histories, is a vital component of the parallel tradition.

The Malla kings, claiming descent from the Licchavi and Karnat lineages of Mithila, were noted for their exceptional patronization of Maithili. Maithili was afforded equal status to Sanskrit in the Malla court, serving as a medium for royal correspondence, poetry, and drama. During this period, the tradition of Maithili songs was integrated into Sanskrit plays, eventually evolving into purely Maithili *Geetinatya* (musical dramas).

Table: Key Maithili Works and Patrons of the Malla Dynasty in Nepal

| King / Patron | Region | Notable Works / Contributions | Genre |
|---|---|---|---|
| Jagatprakash Malla | Bhaktapur | *Prabhavati haran* | Drama / |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | *Natak* | Geeti natya. |
| Jagatjyotir malla | Bhak tapur | *Hargauri Vivah Natak*, *Kunjavihar Natak* | Dram a. |
| Bhupatind ra Malla | Bhak tapur | Composed 26 plays in Maithili | Dram a. |
| Siddhanar ayanadeva | Pata n | *Harishcha ndranritya m* (1620–57) | Multil ingual Dram a. |
| Ranjit Malla | Bhak tapur | 19 identified plays | Dram a. |

The parallel history views this Nepali period as a "classical age" of Newar-Maithili civilization, where the language operated as a cosmopolitan vehicle across the India-Tibet trade route. The sudden end of this tradition in 1768, following the conquest by Prithviraj Narayan Shah, led to a second migration of scholars back toward the Indian heartland, carrying with them a rich theatrical legacy that would eventually inform the *Kirtaniya* traditions of Mithila.

IV

The Ankia Nat and the Brajavali Synthesis in Assam

Simultaneously with the Nepali renaissance, Maithili literature found another home in Assam through the *Ankia Nat* tradition established by Srimanta Sankardeva (1449–1568) and his successor Madhavdev. These plays were written in *Brajavali*, an artificial literary dialect that was fundamentally medieval Maithili with minor Bengali/Assamese alterations.

The parallel history highlights the *Ankia Nat* as a unique genre evolution where the entire drama was written in prose, and the narrator played a central role.

Unlike the courtly dramas of Nepal, these plays were intended for the promotion of the Vaishnava religion among the masses, specifically focusing on the *Vatsalya Leela* (childhood sports) of Krishna.

Notable Ankia Nat Plays archived in the Parallel Tradition:

Sankardev: *Parijatharan*, *Ramvijay.*

Madhavdev: *Bhumi Lutiya Jhumura*, *Pimpara-Guchura-Jhumura*.

Daityari Thakur: *Shyamant Haran Yatra*.

This trans-regional influence demonstrates that Maithili was once the *lingua franca* of Eastern Indian devotionalism, a status that the institutional history often downplays in favor of a more localized, caste-centric identity.

Institutionalization and the Politics of Exclusion: The Sahitya Akademi Critique

The modern era of Maithili literature is dominated by the Sahitya Akademi (National Academy of Letters), established by the Government of India in 1954. While the Akademi's recognition of Maithili in 1965 was a landmark event, the parallel history offers a scathing critique of the institution's subsequent trajectory.

The critique centers on what it calls the "booty distribution" of Sahitya Akademi awards. The foundation of this elitism is traced back to Ramanath Jha, the first convener of the Maithili language at the Akademi. Jha is described by parallel historians as "casteist, conservative, and confused," accused of using his position to suppress liberal writers who attacked social hierarchies. A notable example cited is the denial of the prize to Harimohan Jha, a popular satirist whose works like *Kanyadan* and *Khattar Kakak Tarang* were eligible but were ignored in favor of academic philosophy. This institutional "obscurantism" is seen as a deliberate attempt to keep Maithili as the exclusive domain of a small elite, thereby alienating the broader speech community and hindering the demand for a separate Maithili state.

The Dooshan Panji and the Honour Killing of Gangesh Upadhyaya

A pivotal moment in the parallel historiography is the exposure of the *Dooshan Panji* (the black book of genealogical records). The *Panji* system, established in the 14th century, is a sophisticated genealogical record-keeping method used to maintain caste purity among Maithil Brahmins. The institutional history treats the *Panji* as a mark of cultural distinction. However, the parallel tradition, led by Gajendra Thakur, released digitized copies of these secret records in 2009 to expose their use in social engineering.

The parallel history documents what it calls the "honour killing" of the great *Navya-Nyaya* philosopher Gangesh Upadhyaya (12th century) by institutional historians like Ramanath Jha. While Gangesh is recognized globally for his *Tattvacintamani*, the parallel narrative reveals that he married a "Charmkarini" (a woman from the leather-worker caste) and that his family was born five years after his father's death-facts that elite genealogical records attempted to suppress. By exposing these "secrets," the parallel movement seeks to dismantle the myth of perpetual caste purity that underpins institutional Maithili identity.

Genre Evolution: From Epic Poetry to Subaltern Realism

The development of literary genres in Maithili reflects the broader social shift from courtly elite to subaltern commoner. While early and middle periods were dominated by lyrical poetry and devotional drama, the modern era has seen the rise of prose as a powerful tool for social critique.

The Evolution of the Maithili Novel

The Maithili novel emerged in the early 20th century under the influence of Bengali and Hindi literatures. The parallel history categorizes this development as follows:

Early Modern Phase: Characterized by translations and early social narratives by Rasbiharilal Das and Janardhan Jha.

The Satirical Turn: Harimohan Jha's *Kanyadan* (1933) used satire to attack the conservative marriage customs of Mithila, making it one of the most popular works in the language.

The Subaltern Breakthrough: Jagdish Prasad Mandal's *Pangu* (2021) represents a shift toward depicting the "crippled agricultural system" and the raw realities of village life, away from the romanticized past.

Contemporary Maithili novels now tackle complex issues such as "love jihad," political corruption, and the struggles of the "third gender". Works like *Subhimani Jingi* explore previously untouched social terrains, providing a "new perspective" that the institutional guard often ignores.

Digital Democratization: The Videha Movement

The establishment of the Videha e-journal in 2000 was a response to the perceived stagnation and exclusion of official literary bodies. As the first Maithili fortnightly e-journal, Videha represents a technological-literary movement aimed at bypassing institutional gatekeepers.

The Videha movement's philosophy is built on several pillars:

Digital Sovereignty: By archiving thousands of Maithili books and manuscripts in the "Videha Pothi" and archive, the movement ensures that the language's heritage is accessible to anyone with an internet connection, regardless of caste or geographic location.

Global Translation: Translating Maithili works into English and other languages to provide a "representative review" that contrasts with the "dried main drain" of institutional publications.

Inclusive Archiving: Actively seeking out "non-representative" and subaltern works that have been ignored by official academies.

The journal also promotes "Videha e-Learning" to facilitate the study of the language among the youth, specifically those who may have been alienated by the conservative academic standards. This digital shift is seen as the most viable path forward for Maithili to survive as a modern, living language in the 21st century.

V

Sociopolitical Implications and the Demand for Statehood

The history of Maithili literature is inextricably linked to the demand for a separate Mithila state. In the 1940s, this demand was repeatedly raised on linguistic grounds, fueled by the rich literary heritage documented by Grierson and Mishra. However, the movement failed due to perceived caste dominance. Sociologist T.K. Oommen argues that because the Maithili region is "culturally dominated by Brahmins," other castes feared that a separate state would merely formalize an elite monopoly.

The parallel history supports this sociological insight, suggesting that the "onslaught on dignity" by casteist literary associations has directly hindered the political aspirations of the Maithili speech community. By promoting a "parallel" tradition that includes the stories of all castes and classes, contemporary movements like Videha are attempting to build a broader, more inclusive cultural base that could eventually support a renewed demand for linguistic and political autonomy.

Conclusion: Toward a Synthetic Maithili Future

The parallel history of Maithili literature serves as a critical counter-narrative to the institutionalized standards that have dominated the language since the mid-20th century. By reclaiming the subaltern mysticism of the *Charyapadas*, celebrating the trans-regional diaspora of the Malla kings, and exposing the

gatekeeping mechanisms of the Sahitya Akademi, this parallel tradition offers a more comprehensive and democratic view of the Maithili past.

The digital turn, led by the Videha movement, has successfully shifted the locus of literary power from the physical academy to the decentralized internet. This democratization allows for the inclusion of marginalized voices-the third gender, the landless laborer, and the non-Brahminical intellectual-who were previously excluded from the "mainstream" record. As Maithili continues to navigate the challenges of the 21st century, its survival will likely depend on its ability to integrate these parallel perspectives into a synthetic, inclusive identity that transcends the narrow elitism of the past. The history of Maithili literature is no longer just a history of books; it is a history of resistance, technology, and the ongoing struggle for cultural dignity.

## VI

## The Dialectics of Tradition and Hegemony: A Parallel History of Maithili Literature

The intellectual and cultural historiography of Mithila presents a profound study in the tension between institutionalized canon-building and the organic, often suppressed, voices of a diverse linguistic community. To understand Maithili literature in its entirety, one must navigate between two distinct but intersecting narratives: the "Official History," often associated with the patronage of the Sahitya Akademi and the scholarly lineage of Jayakant Mishra, and the "Parallel History," a critical movement that seeks to reclaim the subaltern, trans-border, and non-elitist dimensions of the Maithili experience. This parallel tradition, exemplified by the works of Radhakrishna Chaudhary and the contemporary Videha movement led by Gajendra Thakur, posits that the standard literary record has functioned as a "dried main drain," filtering out the vibrant contributions of marginalized castes, the Nepal legacy, and the radical realism of modern dissenters.

The geographic and spiritual landscape of Mithila provides the foundational stage for this literary drama. Bounded by the Himalayas and the Ganges, and intercepted by fifteen rivers, the land of Tirabhukti or Mithila has been synonymous with intellectual pursuit since the Vedic age. It is the site where King Videgha Mathava inaugurated Aryan colonization, where Yajnavalkya legislated the Madhyanandini branch of the Shukla Yajurveda, and where Gautama meditated on the foundations of Nyaya philosophy. However, the parallel history movement argues that this classical heritage has been utilized

by entrenched elites to create an exclusionary cultural identity, often reducing a thousand-year-old language to a mere instrument of Brahminical prestige.

The Linguistic Foundation: Evolution and Contest

The genesis of Maithili as an independent speech form represents the first major point of contention in its history. Emerging from the Magadhi Prakrit or Eastern Apabhramsa between the 8th and 11th centuries A.D., Maithili is a senior member of the Eastern Indo-Aryan language family, alongside Bengali, Assamese, and Odia. Institutional historians often emphasize the role of learned scholars in refining the tongue, yet the parallel narrative highlights its survival through strolling bards and common folk who maintained the language despite centuries of "dialectization" by colonial officials and Hindi expansionists.

The Branching of Magadhan Speeches

Linguistic evolution in Eastern India was not a series of isolated events but a parallel development of sister dialects. While Magadhi Prakrit was the court language of the Mauryan Empire and the tongue of the Buddha and Mahavira, it eventually fractured into regional variants.

| Language Period | Developmental Stage | Key Characteristics |
|---|---|---|
| 500 BC - 100 BC | Pali (Early Prakrit) | Canonical Buddhist language |
| 100 BC - 500 AD | Middle Indo-Aryan | Dramatic Prakrits, vernacular usage |
| 500 AD - 1100 AD | Apabhramsa/ Avahatta | Transitional "popular" speech |
| 1100 AD - | New Indo-Aryan | Emergence of Maithili, |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| Present | | Bengali, Assamese |

The distinction between Maithili and its neighbors, particularly Magahi, is often framed by social bias rather than purely linguistic criteria. George Abraham Grierson noted that while Maithili enjoyed the influence of "learned Brahmanas" for centuries, Magahi was condemned as the "uncouth" speech of the south. The parallel history seeks to bridge this gap, recognizing that the "boorish" elements of the language are actually the repositories of original, unadulterated Maithili forms that have survived institutional sanitization.

VII

Scriptural Identity: Mithilakshara vs. Devanagari

The Maithili script, known as Mithilakshara or Tirhuta, is of great antiquity, evolving from an eastern variety of the Gupta script distinct from the Nagari forms. It is an ornamental script, often associated with Tantric Yantra motifs, and was used throughout North-Eastern India, including Tibet and Nepal. The 20th-century transition to Devanagari is often celebrated by institutionalists as a move toward pan-Indian unity, but parallel historians view it with suspicion, as it facilitated the "dialectization" of Maithili under the umbrella of Hindi.

The Early Medieval Synthesis: Siddhacharyas and the Natha Cult

The earliest recorded specimens of Maithili are found in the *Charyapadas*, the mystical songs of the Buddhist Siddhacharyas composed between the 8th and 12th centuries. These songs, written in "Sandhyabhasha" (twilight language), were designed to provide hints for the esoteric Sahajiya cult.

The parallel history of Maithili places these songs at the center of its narrative, arguing that they represent a proto-vernacular stage where Maithili, Bengali, and Assamese were still a common linguistic pool. The *Charyapadas* were not merely religious texts but social documents that criticized caste distinctions and ritualistic pomposity, themes that the institutional history often downplays in favor of their linguistic archaism.

The Subaltern Natha Literature

Closely linked to the Siddhacharyas was the Natha cult, a heterodox tradition of accomplished yogis like Matsyendranath and Gorakshanath. These Naths often belonged to the lower strata of society-sweepers, arrow-makers, and cowherds-

and their literature, captured in ballads like *Goraksha Bijoy*, reflects a fusion of Shaiva philosophy and secret yogic disciplines.

The *Varnanaratnakara* of Jyotirishwar Thakur, the oldest prose work in any North-Eastern Indian language (14th century), meticulously records the names of eighty-four Siddhas, confirming the deep integration of this heterodox tradition in the Maithili cultural landscape. The parallel history emphasizes that this early prose was "stuccato" and "rimed," serving as a handbook for storytellers and common narrators, rather than just a courtly exercise.

Vidyapati Thakur: The Contested Icon

Vidyapati Thakur (c. 1360–1448) is the epicenter of the struggle between official and parallel Maithili histories. To the institutional scholar, he is the "Abhinava Jayadeva," the courtly poet who perfected the *Padavali* and enjoyed the patronage of the Oinwara kings. However, the parallel history movement, particularly through the Videha movement, critiques the "casteist attire" placed upon him.

The Rejection of Sectarian Labels

Vidyapati was a polymath who wrote in Sanskrit, Avahatta, and Maithili. While official histories often label him a "Shaiva" due to his family lineage, the parallel tradition highlights his universalist and realist inclinations. His *Purushapariksha*, for instance, is perhaps the first text in the Indian subcontinent to discuss notions of masculinity and political realism, yet it is often ignored by historians who prefer to view him solely as a singer of divine love.

The parallel history asserts that Vidyapati’s "Desila Bayana" (country speech) was a conscious choice to bridge the gap between the elite and the masses. The movement argues that institutional attempts to claim him as a purely Brahminical icon by organizations like the Chetna Samiti have essentially "murdered" the trans-sectarian and humanist spirit of his poetry.

The Trans-Border Legacy: Maithili in Nepal, Assam, and Bengal

A major blind spot in institutional Maithili historiography is the "Maithili Diaspora," where the language functioned as the primary literary and courtly medium outside the borders of Tirhut for centuries.

VIII

The Malla Kings and the Nepal Tradition

After the Muslim conquest of Tirhut, many Maithila scholars fled to Nepal, where they found sanctuary under the Malla kings of Bhatgaon, Patan, and Kathmandu. Maithili became the language of education and culture in the Nepal Valley.

| Nepal Ruler | Literary Contribution | Impact on Parallel History |
|---|---|---|
| Vishwamalla | Earliest Maithili drama (*Vidya Vilap*) | Proves the early maturity of Maithili theatre |
| Jagajyotirmalla | Authored *Haragauriviv aha* (1629) | Integrated Shiva-Parvati themes with court drama |
| Jitamitramalla | Multi-lingual playwright | Demonstrated Maithili's role as a regional bridge |
| Ranjitamalla | Prolific Maithili poet-king | Represented the zenith of the Nepal-Maithili school |

Parallel historians point out that modern scholars often wrongly categorize this as "Nepali" literature, effectively erasing the Maithili roots of this heritage. This "Nepal Legacy" is a core pillar of the parallel tradition, representing a time when Maithili was an official state language.

Brajabuli and Brajavali: The Artificial Syntheses

In Bengal and Assam, Maithili provided the staple for an artificial literary language known as *Brajabuli* (in Bengal) and *Brajavali* (in Assam).

Brajabuli: Popularized by Vidyapati’s followers, it became the vehicle for the entire medieval Bengali Vaishnava lyric movement. Bengali poets like Narottama Dasa and even Rabindranath Tagore (under the pseudonym Bhanusingha) utilized this Maithili-based dialect.

Brajavali: Created by Srimanta Sankardeva in the 15th century, it mixed Maithili with Assamese to propagate the *Ek-Sarana-Naam-Dharma* movement through *Borgeets* and *Ankia Nats*.

The official history of Bengali and Assamese literature often absorbs these developments, while the official history of Maithili often overlooks them. The parallel history, however, insists that these "Mongrel Languages" are legitimate and vital branches of the Maithili literary tree, demonstrating its historical role as a civilizational lingua franca.

The Drama Traditions: Kirtaniya and Ankia Nat

Maithili literature is unique for its early development of the vernacular drama. The tradition of *Kirtaniya Natak* in Mithila, beginning with Umapati’s *Parijataharana*, was based on the "Naradiya" style of kirtan. These plays were intended for the common folk, using a stylized mix of Sanskrit, Prakrit, and Maithili songs.

IX

Comparative Theatrical Traditions

| Feature | Kirtaniya Natak (Mithila/Nepal) | Ankia Nat (Assam) |
|---|---|---|
| Originat | Umapati | Srimanta |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| or | Upadhyaya (14th C) | Sankardeva (15th C) |
| Language | Sanskrit/Maithili/ Prakrit | Brajavali (Assamese-Maithili mix) |
| Structure | One-act plays, song-heavy | One-act plays, "Bhaona" performance |
| Role of Sutradhar | Leaves stage after Purvaranga | Remains till the end of the performance |

The parallel history argues that Srimanta Sankardeva's travel through Mithila (1481–1493) was the direct catalyst for the *Ankia Nat* tradition. He observed the *Kirtaniya* plays and, inspired by Vidyapati, created a distinct theater form that enlightened the people of Assam. This historical link underscores the "trans-regional" nature of the parallel tradition, which institutionalized histories often fragment into separate provincial narratives.

The Modern "New Awakening" and Institutional Hegemony

The 19th century witnessed a "New Awakening" in Maithili, moving away from decadent documentary prose toward a refined literary style. This renaissance was led by the "Golden Trio"-Chanda Jha, Raghunandan Das, and Lal Das. While this period is often cited as a revival, parallel historians view it as a time when Maithili was simultaneously being "saved" by scholars and "colonized" by the official structures of the British-era permanent settlement.

The Sahitya Akademi and the Politics of Recognition

The official recognition of Maithili by the Sahitya Akademi in 1965 is the most controversial event in the modern period. To Ramanath Jha, the first convener,

this meant the language was "saved". To parallel historians like Gajendra Thakur, it marked the beginning of a period of "casteist conservatism".

The parallel tradition asserts that the Akademi’s advisory boards have consistently been pocket-run by elite caste organizations like the Chetna Samiti and Mithila Sanskritik Parishad, who have used their power to exclude non-Brahmin voices and suppress revolutionary literature. A notable example cited is the "honour killing" of the legacy of Gangesh Upadhyaya, the philosopher whose non-Brahmin or inferior social status was deliberately obscured by institutional scholars to fit a specific caste narrative.

The Gaslighting of Harimohan Jha

Harimohan Jha (1908–1984), arguably the most popular and radical voice of 20th-century Maithili, serves as a primary example of this institutional suppression in the parallel narrative. Despite his immense literary impact through satires like *Khattar Kakak Tarang*, he was consistently denied the Sahitya Akademi award by the "obscurantist elements" who controlled the board. The parallel history views Jha as a figure who "shook the foundations of orthodoxy," which led to his marginalization by the "dried main drain" of official historiography.

Subaltern Heroes and the Folk Heart of Parallel History

While official histories focus on kings and court poets, the parallel history centers on the "Throbbing Human Heart" of folk literature. These traditions, preserved through the oral memory of Dalits and lower castes, represent the true demographic reality of Mithila.

The Pantheon of Subaltern Heroes

| Folk Hero | Narrative Theme | Cultural Significance in Parallel History |
|---|---|---|
| Lorika | Heroic Yadava/Ahir strength | Mentions of "Lorikanacha" as a popular subaltern art |
| Salhes | Dusadha | Established as a |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| a | guardian spirit | "Harijan hero" in Mithila painting |
| Dina-Bhadri | Resistance to bonded labor | Preserved by the Mushahar community; heroic hunters |
| Bihula | Feminine sacrifice and power | Universal appeal across caste lines; snake cult themes |

These folk epics, such as the *Lorik Gita*, which takes thirty-six hours to sing, represent a "living Maithili" that exists independently of printed manuscripts or state academies. The parallel history posits that these are as important to the Maithili heritage as Vidyapati's *Padavali*, but they were historically ignored until researchers like Grierson began to compile them in the 19th century.

X

The Videha Movement and Contemporary Parallel Literature

The contemporary "Parallel History of Maithili Literature" is synonymous with the Videha movement. This movement utilizes digital platforms to bypass institutional gates and give voice to the "missing portions" of society-the non-represented aspects of caste, gender, and socio-economic struggle.

New Dimensions in Contemporary Fiction

Contemporary parallel writers like Rajdeo Mandal and Jagdish Prasad Mandal have broken the traditional erotic and devotional molds to tackle stark realities.

The Third Gender: *Subhimani Jingi* is cited as the first Maithili work to vividly depict the struggles of an adolescent of the "other sex," using the imagery of Ardhanarishwar to advocate for a dignified life.

Environmental Migration: *Kekra Lel Kelau* explores the disconcerted village life following the migration of families to urban centers.

Post-Independence Developmental Critique: *Herayal Jingi* critiques the "faulty development model" and the persistence of caste-based exclusion in rural Mithila after 1947.

The "Non-Caste" Writer: The movement actively promotes writers like Subhash Chandra Yadav (author of *Gulo*), whose works are often dismissed or ignored by "syndicated critical articles" written by elite caste academics.

Philology and the Critique of the Panji System

A central component of the institutional narrative is the *Panji Prabandh*-the highly organized genealogical records of Maithil Brahmins and Kayasthas. While institutional historians like Mm. Parmeshwar Jha present this as a monumental social achievement, the parallel history movement denounces it as a tool of "Brahminical patriarchy" and social exclusion.

Parallel research into the *Panji* files suggests that sub-castes like the "Srotriyas" did not exist before 1800 C.E. and were an artificial creation of the permanent settlement era to consolidate elite power. This critique is vital to the parallel tradition because it deconstructs the "sacred" basis upon which much of the institutional Maithili identity is built.

Conclusion: Toward a Synthetic Historiography

The "Parallel History of Maithili Literature" is more than a list of alternative texts; it is a fundamental shift in perspective that refuses to see Maithili as the exclusive preserve of a courtly or priestly elite. It is an "exhaustive in its detail" attempt to reintegrate the Nepal legacies, the Assamese *Brajavali* dramas, the Dalit folk heroes, and the modern progressive dissenters into a unified, democratic account of the Maithili-speaking world.

The history of Maithili literature remains a contested terrain. On one hand stands the "Official Tradition," focused on classical poise, institutional recognition, and the sanitized memory of the past. On the other stands the "Parallel Tradition," rooted in the "throbbing human heart," subaltern resistance, and the "clean slate" of a representational future. As Maithili writers navigate the complexities of the 21st century-from the 8th Schedule of the Indian Constitution to the digital archives of Videha-the synthesis of these two histories will be the ultimate measure of the language’s vitality and dignity.

XI

MAITHILI LITERATURE IN PARALLEL HISTORY: based on Radhakrishna Chaudhary’s A Survey of Maithili Literature (2010)

*Synthesised with External Scholarly Sources*

This research examines the history of Maithili literature as presented in Radhakrishna Chaudhary's authoritative survey (Shruti Publications, 2010), placed in the light of parallel literary developments across eastern India-Bengali, Assamese, Oriya, and Nepali traditions. The study traces Maithili's evolution from its proto-Magadhi roots through three broad epochs: Early (c. 900–1350 A.D.), Middle (c. 1350–1830 A.D.), and Modern (1830 to date). It analyses how Maithili did not develop in isolation but acted as a lingua franca, a donor language, and a civilisational anchor for a vast trans-regional literary culture. Central to the study is the figure of Vidyapati Thakur (c. 1360–1480), whose influence on Bengali Vaishnavism, Assamese Ankianata drama, Oriya Brajabuli poetry, and Nepali court literature constitutes one of the most remarkable instances of literary transfusion in pre-modern India. The report also examines how modern Maithili's revival under Chanda Jha, the Grierson grammar, and twentieth-century writers parallels similar vernacular renaissances across colonial Bengal and Bihar, and concludes with an assessment of Maithili's current status as a Scheduled Language still seeking classical recognition.

XII

## Introduction: A Language in Historical Context

Maithili occupies a unique position in the literary history of the Indian subcontinent. Among the oldest of the new Indo-Aryan languages, it emerged as an independent speech around the tenth century A.D. from the eastern branch of Magadhi Prakrit. Unlike many regional languages that grew in relative isolation, Maithili from its earliest period functioned as a cultural bridge-exporting its literary forms to Nepal, Bengal, Assam, and Orissa while absorbing impulses from Sanskrit, Avahatta, Arabic, and Persian. Its homeland, the historic region of Mithila (bounded by the Himalayas to the north and the Ganges to the south, encompassing modern Darbhanga, Madhubani, Muzaffarpur, and parts of Nepal's Terai), was renowned since Vedic times as a seat of philosophy, law, and music.

Radhakrishna Chaudhary's survey, originally prepared for the Sahitya Akademi but eventually published independently, stands as one of the most comprehensive accounts of Maithili literature in the English language. Written in the tradition of exhaustive scholarly surveys, it traces the language's development from its Charyapada origins to the mid-twentieth century, covering poetry, prose, drama, and folk literature. This report places that

internal history in dialogue with parallel developments in neighbouring literary traditions and with contemporary scholarship, to illuminate what makes Maithili's trajectory both distinctive and representative of a wider eastern Indian literary modernity.

A foundational premise of this study is that literary histories are best understood comparatively. Just as one cannot understand Italian Renaissance literature without French and Latin parallels, Maithili literature reaches its fullest significance when read alongside the Bengali Vaishnava Padavali, the Assamese Ankianata, Nepali Malla court poetry, and the colonial-era revival movements that swept eastern India from the 1830s onward.

XIII

## Linguistic Origins and Parallel Evolution

### Descent from Magadhi Prakrit

The linguistic genealogy of Maithili is traced by Chaudhary-and confirmed by Grierson, S.K. Chatterji, Sukumar Sen, and Subhadra Jha-to the Magadhi Prakrit that served as the speech of the Maurya eastern empire. The Ashokan edicts, inscribed in a vernacular close to this Magadhi, reveal at least four regional varieties by the third century B.C. The eastern variety, developed in the Mithila-Magadha corridor, gave birth not only to Maithili but also to Bengali, Assamese, and Oriya. This shared genealogy means that the literary histories of these languages are not simply parallel-they are, in their earliest phases, intertwined and mutually constitutive.

Sarvananda's eleventh-century commentary on the Amarakosha preserves some four hundred Maithili words, offering the earliest lexicographic evidence of an independent Maithili speech distinct from Apabhramsa. The Charyapadas (c. 700–1200 A.D.), Buddhist mystical songs written in Sandhya-bhasha by Vajrayana siddhas from the Mithila-Assam-Bengal corridor, are claimed as ancestral texts by all the eastern languages. Scholars like Rahul Sankrityayan, Subhadra Jha, and Jayakant Mishra have argued that several siddhas-including Kanhapa and Sarhapa-were from Mithila, and that the language of these padas shows particular affinity with early Maithili morphology. This claim is disputed by Bengali scholars, and the debate is itself emblematic of the rivalry over literary priority that has long complicated eastern Indian literary historiography.

## The Script Tradition: Tirhuta / Mithilakshara

The Maithili script-known as Tirhuta or Mithilakshara-is itself a parallel tradition to the Bengali and Assamese scripts, all descending from the Siddhamatrika script of the Gupta period. The earliest epigraphic evidence of a proto-Maithili script is found in the Mandar Hill Stone inscriptions of Adityasena (seventh century A.D.), now preserved at the Baidyanath temple in Deoghar. By the medieval period, this script had spread to Nepal (where it was used for royal documents) and to Bengal and Assam (where scholars writing Maithili texts employed it alongside their own scripts). The parallel spread of scripts mirrors the parallel spread of literary forms-both driven by the cultural prestige of Mithila as a centre of Sanskrit and Nyaya learning.

XIV

Early Maithili Literature (c. 900–1350 A.D.): The Triumph of the Vernacular

## Historical and Dynastic Context

The real history of Mithila as an independent cultural unit begins, as Chaudhary notes, in 1097 A.D. with the Karnata dynasty under Nanyadeva. This coincides, significantly, with the period in which many north Indian vernacular literatures were crystallising out of Apabhramsa. The Karnatas were not only warriors but connoisseurs of music and Sanskrit scholarship. Nanyadeva's Saraswatihridayalankarahara (c. 1097–1147) is among the earliest texts linking the joining of metre with melody-a feature that would become the defining characteristic of Maithili lyric poetry. His work influenced Jayadeva's Gitagovinda (c. 1180), which in turn cast its shadow over all subsequent Maithili and Bengali lyric poetry.

This is the first major parallel: as Bengali literature was gestating its own lyric tradition through the Charyapadas and proto-Vaishnava devotional poetry, Maithili was developing a complementary but distinct lyric vocabulary rooted in Sanskrit prosody, Apabhramsa melody, and vernacular diction. The two traditions would converge explosively in the Brajabuli synthesis of the fifteenth and sixteenth centuries.

## Jyotirishwar Thakur and the Varnanaratnakara

The single most important monument of early Maithili prose is the Varnanaratnakara of Jyotirishwar Thakur (c. 1280–1340), composed under the patronage of Harisimhadeva, last great ruler of the Karnata dynasty. Chaudhary describes it as 'the earliest and the longest specimen of the early new Indo-

Aryan prose'-a staccato, rhymed prose encyclopaedia in seven Kallolas (chapters) covering urban life, heroic ideals, seasons, the arts, military campaigns, music, and cosmology. Its importance is parallel to that of the Manasollasa of Someshvara (twelfth century Sanskrit) or the Lilavati of Mahendra Suri-texts that perform both literary and encyclopaedic functions.

S.K. Chatterji's introduction to the Varnanaratnakara recognises it as a document of 'first-rate importance in the study of culture in early and mid-medieval times in northern India.' The work's language is more archaic than anything in the later Vidyapati corpus, suggesting a rich pre-existing tradition of Maithili prose cultivation. Crucially, the VR was studied in Mithila, Nepal, and Bengal as late as the sixteenth century, evidencing its status as a pan-eastern standard text.

### Umapati Upadhyaya and Early Lyric Drama

Umapati Upadhyaya's Parijataharananataka (drama, with twenty-one lyrical songs in Maithili) is the earliest surviving Maithili drama and predates the vernacular drama of Bengal and Assam by at least a generation. The songs display, as Sukumar Sen noted, features more archaic than anything in Vidyapati-forms closer to Avahatta Apabhramsa-yet they are also finished literary compositions of considerable sophistication. The drama's introduction of vernacular songs within a Sanskrit-Prakrit dramatic framework establishes the model that would characterise Maithili dramatic literature for centuries and that would be emulated in the Ankianata tradition of Assam under Sankaradeva.

# XV

# The Age of Efflorescence: Vidyapati and His World

### Vidyapati Thakur (c. 1360–1480):

Born at Bishaphi in the second half of the fourteenth century into a family of distinguished Maithila Brahmin scholars (his ancestor Chandeshwar compiled the seven-volume Ratnakaras, still the foundation of Maithili social law), Vidyapati was polymath, courtier, law-giver, philosopher, and poet. His influence on making Avahattha into a literary language has been compared to

that of Dante in Italian and Chaucer in English-a comparison that captures the simultaneous act of vernacularisation and canonisation he performed.

His works span multiple genres and languages: the Kirtilata and Kirtipataka in Avahatta (Maithili Apabhramsa), the Purushapariksha and other Sanskrit treatises on ethics, law, and ritual, the Gorakshavijaya drama, became the standard against which all subsequent Brajabuli poetry was measured.

## Vidyapati and Sivasimha: Court, Exile, and Creative Freedom

The relationship between Vidyapati and his principal patron Sivasimha (who ascended the Oinwara throne in Saka 1324 / 1402–3 A.D.) is one of the defining creative partnerships in Indian literary history. From a copper plate grant, we learn that Sivasimha called Vidyapati 'the new Jayadeva' and granted him his home village of Bishaphi. The courtly environment-and Sivasimha's own love of music and sensuous beauty-freed Vidyapati to compose his erotic and devotional lyrics in Maithili, breaking with the tradition of composing love poetry exclusively in Sanskrit. After Sivasimha disappeared in battle with a Muslim army in 1406, Vidyapati and the court took refuge at Rajabanauli in modern Nepal-an exile that deepened his devotional poetry and extended Maithili's reach into the Malla court.

Chaudhary observes that Vidyapati was driven by a dual compulsion: to satisfy courtly demand for erotic poetry, and to use that poetry as a vehicle for fortifying Hindu identity against Muslim political pressure. The result was an extraordinary synthesis-sensuous, devotional, politically resonant-that spoke simultaneously to multiple audiences. This is paralleled in the Bengal of Chandidasa, where a similar synthesis of erotic and devotional Vaishnava poetry was taking place at roughly the same time, and the two traditions-Maithili and proto-Bengali-fed and reinforced each other.

## Poetic Technique and Influence

Vidyapati's poetic technique draws on Sanskrit aesthetics (the eight rasas, the nayika-nayaka typology, the standard images of erotic poetry) but deploys them in the 'simple, musical, and direct' Maithili vernacular. His verse is characterised by moraic metre, alliterative texture, the use of the Bhanita (poet's signature in the final stanza)-a practice found across all eastern Indian medieval literatures-and an extraordinary range of imagery drawn from contemporary village and court life. As Chaudhary writes, 'Because of the raciness and crispness of the language, many of his lines have passed into common speech.'

Scholarly consensus, across both Maithili and Bengali traditions, is that the Vaishnava saints of Bengal-most crucially Chaitanya Mahaprabhu (1486–1534)-encountered Vidyapati's songs not as literary artifacts but as lived spiritual expression. Biographies of Chaitanya report that he would sing the songs of Jayadeva, Vidyapati, and Chandidasa through the night. This encounter between a Maithili literary tradition and a Bengali devotional movement was catalytic: it generated the hybrid literary language known as Brajabuli and launched the most prolific phase of Vaishnava lyric poetry in eastern India.

## XVI

## The Mongrel Language: Brajabuli as Pan-Eastern Literary Medium

The emergence of Brajabuli is the most striking instance of Maithili literature's trans-regional influence and deserves extended treatment in any parallel history. Brajabuli is described by Chaudhary, following S.K. Chatterji, as 'a kind of Maithili, mixed with Bengali in Bengal and Assamese in Assam, with some earlier Apabhramsa and contemporary western Brajabhasha forms.' It developed from the fourteenth century onward as Vaishnava singers from Bengal and Assam-having absorbed Vidyapati's Maithili lyric tradition through the Bengali students who studied Nyaya in Mithila and carried songs back with them-began composing their own padas in an artificial literary language modelled on Maithili but inflected with their own mother tongues.

Grierson, who first analysed Brajabuli systematically, called its emergence 'an unparalleled circumstance in the history of literature.' Sukumar Sen argued that Brajabuli was created in the hands of Bengali poets imitating Vidyapati's Padavali; at a later stage he revised this view and related it more closely to Avahatta ancestry. More recent scholarship-including a 2019 essay in the Journal of South Asian Languages and Linguistics analysing manuscripts at the Asiatic Society of Bengal-has confirmed that while thousands of padas in Bengali padavalis are attributed to Vidyapati, only a small fraction can be directly traced to authenticated Maithili sources; the majority represent Bengali poets writing in Brajabuli under Vidyapati's prestige.

## Bengali Brajabuli

The great Bengali Brajabuli poets-Govindadasa Kabiraja, Jnanadasa, Narottamadasa, Balaramadasa-composed padas in this hybrid tongue that became liturgically central to Gaudiya Vaishnavism. Govindadasa, described by Chaudhary as ‘almost the greatest after Vidyapati,’ excels in ‘verbal harmony’ and ‘matchless alliterations.’ Balaramadasa surpasses all Bengali Brajabuli poets in metrical skill. The tradition persisted until the late nineteenth century when Bengali reformers adopted contemporary Bengali as their literary medium. Significantly, Rabindranath Tagore-at the height of the Bengal Renaissance-composed his early Bhanusingha Thakurer Padavali (1884) in Brajabuli, initially promoting these lyrics as the work of a newly discovered medieval poet named Bhanusingha. The hoax, though eventually revealed, testifies to Brajabuli’s living literary vitality even in the era of print and colonial modernity.

## Assamese Brajavali

In Assam, the parallel development is known as Brajavali. Sankaradeva (c. 1449–1586), the founder of Ekasarana Vaishnavism and the Ankianata dramatic tradition, composed his Baragitis (celestial songs) and much of his drama in Brajavali-a medium that drew on Maithili morphology, Assamese vocabulary, and some Avadhi and Brajabhasha elements. Chaudhary notes that in Assamese Brajavali, Maithili words predominate, reflecting the depth of Sankaradeva’s debt to the Mithila tradition. A 2015 contrastive linguistic study (published in Language in India) confirms that while Assamese Brajavali and early Maithili share significant morphological features, they are distinct language forms-the Assamese tradition developing independently under its own formal constraints.

## Oriya Brajabuli

In Orissa, the Brajabuli tradition is inaugurated by Ramananda Raya, governor of the Godavari province under the Gajapati king Prataprudra Deva and disciple of Chaitanya. His language is described as Maithili mixed with Brajabhasha, Bengali, and Oriya. Vidyapati’s influence reached Orissa through Bengal, and other notable Oriya Brajabuli poets include Champati Ray and King Pratap Malla Dev (1504–32). Chaudhary characterises this as a ‘case of direct participation in a common literary life in eastern India’-a phrase that captures the essentially collaborative nature of the Brajabuli phenomenon.

XVII

## Maithili Drama: Nepal and the Kirtaniya Tradition

The history of Maithili drama constitutes another major strand of the parallel history of eastern Indian literature. Maithili's dramatic tradition, which predates the vernacular drama of Bengal and Assam, spread to Nepal under the Malla kings and became for a period the court language of Kathmandu, Patan, and Bhatgaon.

The earliest extant Maithili drama-Jyotirishwar's Dhurtasamagamanataka-was discovered in Nepal, where the manuscript tradition of Maithili literature was better preserved than in Mithila itself (much as early Bengali manuscripts were preserved in Nepal). Umapati's Parijatahararananataka established the model of Sanskrit-Prakrit drama with interspersed Maithili songs. Vidyapati followed and extended this model in his Gorakshavijaya, and the tradition crossed the border into Nepal, where from the seventeenth century onward Maithili drama flourished at its height under the Malla kings. Chaudhary notes that in Nepal, 'For about one hundred and fifty years, Maithili drama flourished at its height, replacing the Sanskrit drama for all practical purposes.'

Among the Malla poet-kings, Jagajyotirmalla (1613–1633), Jagatprakashamalla, Siddhinarayana Malla, and Bhupatindra Malla (1695–1722) composed extensively in Maithili. Bhupatindra Malla alone wrote twenty-six Maithili plays-an output comparable to any professional dramatist of the period. The Kirtaniya drama tradition-combining devotional song, gesture, and narrative in a form peculiar to Mithila-parallels the Ankianata of Assam as an instance of how Vaishnavism generated new dramatic forms across eastern India simultaneously.

XVIII

## Heritage Without Glamour: Decline and the Mongrel Middle Period

The period roughly between 1600 and 1830 is characterised by Chaudhary as one of 'decadent documentary prose' and literary decline. The political context is significant: the Khandwala dynasty (from c. 1556 A.D.) revived Maithili patronage briefly under Mahesha Thakur and his successors, but the growing influence of Brajabhasha (the Hindi lingua franca of north Indian Vaishnava

devotion, associated with the birthplace of Krishna) created a competitive environment for Maithili literature. The hybrid ‘mongrel language’ of the period-blending Maithili with Brajabhasha-lacked the polish of either. As Chaudhary puts it, ‘The growing popularity of Brajabhasha was due to the fact that it was associated with the birth-place of Krishna, whose legends grew popular in the middle ages in the wake of the growing Vaishnava faith.’

This decline is paralleled in Bengal, where the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries saw a similar tension between vernacular Bengali and Brajabhasha in devotional literature, and in Assam, where the post-Sankaradeva period saw a gradual petrification of the Ankianata tradition. Yet the parallel histories diverge in one crucial respect: Bengali literature, buttressed by its larger demographic base and the economic energies of Mughal Bengal, maintained a richer literary output through the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries, while Maithili experienced a more pronounced fallow period.

XIX

## The New Awakening: Colonial Modernity and the Maithili Revival

### The Grierson Effect

The colonial period brought a paradoxical intervention in Maithili literary history. George Abraham Grierson-the Irish civil servant and linguist who served in Bihar-was the first to produce a systematic grammar of Maithili (1881), a comprehensive bibliography of Maithili manuscripts, and a catalogue of Mithila MSS. His insistence that Maithili was a distinct language (rather than a dialect of Bengali or Bihari, as some contemporary scholars claimed) provided the intellectual armature for a Maithili nationalist movement. This is closely parallel to the role played by English Orientalists in legitimising Bengali and Sanskrit literary traditions during the Bengal Renaissance: the colonial gaze, however condescending, inadvertently catalysed native literary self-consciousness.

### Chanda Jha and the Modern Renaissance

The figure of Chanda Jha (1831–1907) in modern Maithili literature is analogous to Bankimchandra Chattopadhyay in Bengali-both men who, in the mid-to-late nineteenth century, redirected their literary tradition toward new social and aesthetic purposes while anchoring it in a recovered vernacular

pride. Chanda Jha's Mithila Bhasha Ramayan demonstrated that Maithili was capable of sustaining a sustained epic narrative-not merely devotional songs and documentary prose-and thereby challenged the dominant view of Maithili as a language 'fit only for light literature.' He served the court of Maharaja Lakshmishwar Singh of Darbhanga, and his work represents the best example of what colonial patronage and personal conviction could achieve for a subordinated literary tradition.

The website dedicated to Chanda Jha's legacy describes his contribution in terms that consciously parallel Vidyapati: 'What Vidyapati did for Maithili in the 14th Century has been done by Chanda Jha in the 19th Century and perhaps his contribution is more profound than the former.' This is the kind of retrospective canonisation that marks the consolidation of a literary tradition-the construction of a lineage that gives the present moment its authority.

## The First Maithili Journal and Linguistic Politics

The first Maithili journal, Maithil-Hit-Sadhana, was founded in 1905 by Madhusudan Jha and Chandra Dutta Jha from Jaipur-the same year as the Partition of Bengal and the height of the Swadeshi movement. The parallel with Bengali and other regional literatures is unmistakable: across India, the early twentieth century saw a proliferation of vernacular journals and literary societies that functioned as vehicles of cultural nationalism. In Mithila, this movement was complicated by caste politics: the Darbhanga Raj's lackadaisical approach to Maithili, the literacy rate of barely five percent (concentrated almost entirely in upper-caste households), and the subordination of the lower castes to forms of cultural production they could not easily access, all constrained the emergence of a broad-based Maithili literary nationalism.

As the scholarly paper published in JETIR (2019) observes, 'these developments, detrimental to the emergence of a homogenous elite group, constricted their sense' of Maithili as a unified political identity. Vidyapati became the icon of the Maithili revival-but the revival's social base remained narrow compared to the Bengali and Hindi renaissances.

XX

## The Golden Trio and Twentieth-Century Modernity

Chaudhary's chapter 'The Golden Trio' refers to the cluster of eminent early-twentieth-century Maithili writers who synthesised the lyric heritage of the medieval period with the social and aesthetic concerns of modernity. Maithili prose fiction-the novel and short story-emerged in this period, with Hari Mohan Jha's satirical fiction and B.K. Verma 'Manipadma's dramas representing the two major achievements of mid-century literary modernism. The short story, in particular, developed in Maithili in close dialogue with the Bengali short story tradition-itself shaped by Tagore, Prabhat Kumar Mukhopadhyay, and Manik Bandyopadhyay-with Maithili writers adapting the form to the distinctive social textures of north Bihar: the joint family, the Panji genealogical system, the rituals of Maithila Brahmin life, and the poverty of the Kosi flood plain.

The poetry of the modern period extended the lyric tradition of Vidyapati while absorbing the influence of English Romantic and modernist forms. Sitaram Jha pioneered blank verse (Muktakakavya) in Maithili. Later poets engaged with the free verse revolution that swept across Indian literatures in the 1930s–50s, producing a genuinely modern Maithili poetic idiom while continuing to compose in the traditional Nacharis, Maheshvanis, and folk song forms that remained living parts of Mithila's cultural life.

The inclusion of Maithili in the Eighth Schedule of the Indian Constitution in 2003-after decades of advocacy-represents the most significant institutional recognition the language has received. It enables Maithili to be used as a medium of instruction, examined in competitive examinations, and supported with state resources for publication and cultural preservation. However, as the Wikipedia article on Maithili language notes, Maithili missed out on Classical Language status in the October 2024 round of recognitions (which included Assamese, Bengali, Marathi, Pali, and Prakrit) due to the absence of a formal proposal from the Bihar state government-a telling example of how political indifference can retard the recognition of literary traditions of great antiquity.

# XXI

# Critical Assessment: Strengths and Limitations of Chaudhary's Survey

## Contributions

Radhakrishna Chaudhary's survey is a work of genuine scholarship and evident love for his subject. Its strengths are considerable. It is the most comprehensive single-volume account of Maithili literature in English, covering poetry, prose, drama, and folk literature across all three periods. Its treatment of the pre-Vidyapati period is particularly valuable, drawing on manuscript evidence and epigraphic records to reconstruct a literary tradition that is poorly known even among specialists. Its discussion of Brajabuli and Maithili's trans-regional influence is nuanced and well-sourced, drawing on the best scholarship of S.K. Chatterji, Sukumar Sen, and P.C. Bagchi.

## Limitations and Gaps

The survey has several significant limitations that a parallel historical reading makes apparent. First, the treatment of lower-caste and non-Brahmin literary traditions is thin. The rich oral and folk traditions of the Yadav, Kayastha, Dom, and other communities-including the great ballads of Salhesa, Bihula, and Lorika, which Chaudhary acknowledges but does not analyse in depth-remain outside the survey's primary focus. Second, women's literary contributions are marginalised. Chandrakala, granddaughter of Vidyapati, is mentioned; but the rich tradition of women's folk songs (Sohar, Samadauni, Lagni) and occasional named women poets receives no sustained treatment. Third, the modern period is dealt with more as a bibliography than as a critical literary history-the appended lists of recent publications are informative but analytically thin.

Fourth, and perhaps most significantly for a parallel history, Chaudhary's survey is insufficiently comparative. The Bengali, Assamese, and Nepali parallels are acknowledged but rarely drawn out analytically. A twenty-first-century reader seeking to understand how Maithili's trajectory relates to those of its sister traditions would need to supplement Chaudhary extensively with Sukumar Sen's History of Bengali Literature, Birinchi Kumar Barua's History of Assamese Literature, and Jayakant Mishra's two-volume history of Maithili language and literature.

XXII

## Parallel History: A Comparative Timeline

The following represents a synthesis of Chaudhary's periodisation with the parallel developments in Bengali, Assamese, Nepali, and Oriya literatures:

| Period | Maithili | Bengali | Assamese / Nepali | Shared Event |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| c.700–1100 | Charyapadas (proto-Maithili); Daka, Ghagha aphorisms | Charyapadas claimed by Bengali tradition | Charyapadas; proto-Assamese dialect | Common Buddhist Doha tradition |
| c.1097–1350 | Karnata dynasty; Jyotirishwar VR; Umapati Parijataharana | Proto-Vaishnava songs; Chandidasa emerging | Nanyadeva music theory influences Assam | Vernacular challenge to Sanskrit begins |
| c.1350–1480 | Vidyapati Padavali; Kirtilata; court of Oinwaras | Chandidasa; early Brajabuli forms | Vidyapati songs adopted in Nepal Malla courts | Brajabuli synthesis begins |
| c.1480–1600 | Govindadasa; Kamsanarayan; Maithili drama in Nepal | Chaitanya movement; Govindadasa Kabiraja Brajabuli | Sankaradeva Brajavali; Ankianata drama | Vaishnava pan-eastern literary culture peaks |
| c.1600–1830 | Khandwala dynasty; Lochana RT; literary stagnation | Vaishnava padavali peak; prose emerging | Post-Sankaradeva consolidation; Maithili plays in | Brajabuli declines as Bengali asserts itself |

| Period | Maithili | Bengali | Assamese / Nepali | Shared Event |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | | Nepal | |
| 1830–1900 | Chanda Jha revival; Grierson grammar (1881) | Bengal Renaissance; Bankim; Brajabuli nostalgia (Tagore) | Assamese literary society; Orunodoi journal (1846) | Colonial modernity reshapes all vernacular traditions |
| 1900–2003 | Mithil-Hit-Sadhana journal; 8th Schedule agitation | Tagore Nobel; Bengali modernism | Assamese gains state language status (1960) | Constitutional recognition of vernacular identities |

# XXIII

## Conclusion: Maithili as a ‘Donor’ Civilisation

The parallel history of Maithili literature reveals a tradition that, despite its geopolitical confinement to a relatively small region of north Bihar and the Nepal Terai, exercised an outsize influence on the literary cultures of eastern India for nearly six centuries. From the Charyapadas to the Brajabuli synthesis to the Kirtaniya drama, Maithili has been more often a donor than a recipient of literary forms-exporting prosody, imagery, vocabulary, and aesthetic norms to Bengali, Assamese, Oriya, and Nepali traditions that were simultaneously developing their own autonomous literary identities.

This paradox-a tradition of enormous influence that has long struggled for political and institutional recognition-is explained by a combination of factors: the domination of Sanskrit (which delayed vernacular self-consciousness among Maithila Brahmin scholars), the political weakness of Mithila under successive Muslim and British administrations, the narrow social base of the

literary revival, and the absorption of Maithili cultural prestige into the larger Bengali and Hindi literary systems without adequate acknowledgement. The debates over whether Vidyapati was 'really' Maithili or Bengali, whether the Charyapadas belong to Maithili or Bengali or Assamese literary history, whether Brajabuli is a dialect of Maithili or a Bengali creation-all these are symptoms of this structural paradox.

Radhakrishna Chaudhary's survey, for all its limitations, performs an invaluable act of cultural assertion: it insists on the integrity and coherence of Maithili as a literary tradition, refuses the reduction of that tradition to a branch of any other language, and lays out the evidence for Maithili's historical primacy in the lyric, prosodic, dramatic, and encyclopaedic traditions of eastern India. Read alongside the scholarship of Jayakant Mishra, Sukumar Sen, S.K. Chatterji, and the growing body of postcolonial and sociolinguistic research on Maithili identity, it remains an essential foundation for understanding the literary history not just of Mithila, but of the entire eastern Indo-Aryan cultural sphere.

As of March 2026, Maithili continues to campaign for Classical Language status from the Government of India-a status that would acknowledge the antiquity and influence documented in this report. The campaign's eventual success would not merely be a political achievement; it would be a recognition that the parallel history of eastern Indian literature has a name that too long went unrecorded: Maithili.

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ADDENDUM

A Survey of Maithili Literature- Volume II- Introduction

FESTIVAL OF LETTERS OR FESTIVAL OF SHAME

SAHITYA AKADEMI AND the DOWNFALL OF INDIAN LANGUAGES (IN SPECIAL CONTEXT OF MAITHILI LANGUAGE)

When Maithili was recognised by the Sahitya Akademi (National Academy of Letters- of India) way back in 1965, Late Ramanath Jha stated that his Maithili language is saved now (Maithilik Vartman Samasya, Ramanath Jha).

He was wrong on this on two counts. What he referred to as applicable, if it applied at all, only to the part of Maithili speaking area, geographically located

in India. Maithili is spoken, natively, in India and Nepal. After the treaty of sugauli (ratified in 1816), which was in the aftermath of the Anlo-Nepalese war of 1814-16, the hilly regions were incorporated in British India, including the Nepalese-speaking Darjeeling Area. Similarly in 1816 and 1860, the Britishers ceded some Terai region to Nepal. As a result part of Maithili speaking Area, which was earlier ruled by Malla Kings (when Maithili was an official language of the region), was ceded to Nepal. Even today some Maithili scholars (!!) refer to the golden period of Maithili as the period of "Nepali (!!)" Malla Kings (Ramanath Jha, Introduction to Maithili Sahityak Itihas by Dr Durganath Jha "Shreesh").

Ramanath Jha himself admits that during his visit to "Vir Library" of Nepal (Kathmandu) he came to know about the Nepal legacy (his monograph on kirtaniya Natak, which he wrongly presents as Kirtaniya Nach) in respect of Maithili. So he cannot be blamed for his lack of knowledge in this respect. He was wrong on the second count also, and this second count was an artificial creation. He began a tradition of elitism and conservatism in Sahitya Akademi, as the first convener of the Maithili language. The tradition got stronger and stronger in the last 55 years of the Existence of Maithili in that Akademi. So he ensured that the liberal writers, like Sh. Harimohan Jha, attacking casteism and conservatism did not get the award, even though the year 1967 went unrewarded and the Ist award in 1966 was given to a non-literary book in Maithili (academic book of Philosophy!!!).

He was casteist, conservative and confused. The inter-caste marriage in Panji was well known to him, and it was apparent that the great navya-nyaya philosopher Gangesh Upadhyaya married a "Charmkarini" and was born five years after the death of his father. But he informed Sh. Dinesh Chandra Bhattacharya in a distorted way. Sh. Dinesh Chandra Bhattacharya writes in the "History of Navya-Nyaya in Mithila"-

"The family which was inferior in social status is now extinct in Mithila-Gangesha’s family is completely ignored and we are not expected to know even his father’s name.", and he writes further that all this information was given to him by Prof. R. Jha. So how would this casteist-conservative-confused allow the award to be given to Sh? Harimohan Jha. So the Sahitya Akademi saved the Maithili Language by recognizing it, as asserted by Prof. R. Jha, was wrong on those two counts.

Now come to Nepal, the Prajna Pratisthan and other organizations often recognize Indian Maithili writers, but Sahitya Akademi of India does not recognize Nepalese Maithili writers, be it the Seminars or the poets meet, be it

an anthology of poems or prose published by the Akademi. Regarding the treatment of Nepalese Maithili writers by Sahitya Akademi Sh. Ram Bharos Kapari "Bhramar" laments that there is demand in Nepal that they should also not award Indian Maithili writers/ publish them in their anthologies as reciprocity demands this.

The narrow-mindedness of the Maithili advisory board of the Indian Sahitya Akademi has its origin in the organizations that are recognized by the Sahitya Akademi, the basis of which is extra-literary credentials. These are pseudo-organizations running on paper, political organizations or casteist organizations pocket-run by a few. The complete list is:

MAITHILI LITERARY ASSOCIATIONs (!!!) RECOGNIZED by SAHITYA AKADEMI

1. The Secretary, All India Maithili Sahitya Samiti, Tirbhukti, 1/1B, Sir P.C. Banerjee Road, Allahabad-211 002;

2. The General Secretary, Akhil Bharatiya Maithili Sahitya Parishad, C/o Dr. Ganapati Mishra, Lalbag, Darbhanga-846 004;

3. The Secretary, Chetna Samity, Vidyapati Bhawan, Vidyapati Marg, Patna-800 001;

4. The Secretary, Mithila Sanskritik Parishad, 6 B, Kailash Saha Lane, Kolkata-700 007;

5. The Secretary, Vidyapati Seva Sansthan, Mithila Bhavan Parishar, Darbhanga-846 004;

6. The Secretary, Centre for the Study of Indian Traditions, Tantrabati Geeta Bhavan; Ranti House, Ranti, Madhubani-847 211

Now the Literary Association lists read as under. Serial no. 1 & 6 above have been derecognised and has been replaced by other non-literary associations at sr no 5, 6 & 7 below.

(1)The General Secretary, Akhil Bharatiya Maithili Sahitya Parishad, Professors' Colony, Digahi West

Opp. of Primary School, Darbhanga-846 004, (Bihar)

2) The Secretary, Chetna Samiti, Vidhya Pati Bhavan, Vidyapati Marg, Patna-800 001 (Bihar)

3) The Secretary, Mithila Sanskritik Parishad, 6B, Kailash Saha Lane, Kolkata-700 007, (West Bengal)

4) The Secretary, Vidhya Pati Sewa Sansthan, Mithila Bhavan Parishar, Darbhanga-846 004, (Bihar)

5) The Secretary, Anand, Samajik Sanskritik Sahityik Manch, Rajkumarganj (Mirzapur Chowk), Darbhanga-846 004, (Bihar)

6) The General Secretary, Mithila Sanskritik Parishad, Rosebery 5032, Sahara Garden City, Adityapur-2

Jamshedpur-831 014, (Jharkhand)

7) The General Secretary, Akhil Bharatiya Mithila Sangh, G-6, Hans Bhavan, Wing 2 I.T.O., Bahadurshah Zafar Marg, New Delhi-110 002, (Delhi)

What is the literary credential of the Centre for the Study of Indian Traditions (now recognised and replaced by a pocket association)? Chetna Samiti and Vidyapati Seva Sansthan are casteist political outfits, vehemently displaying the casteist attire of a great ancient poet, whose caste is still uncertain (VIDYAPATI), but who was certainly not Brahmin. All India Maithili Sahitya Samiti (now derecognised and replaced by a non-literary association) became non-existent even during the lifetime of the Late Jaykant Mishra, same is the case with Akhil Bhartiya Maithili Sahitya Parishad. Mithila Sanskritik Parishad has done a crime through an investiture ceremony of the great Vidyapati, they tried to convert Vidyapati and "Maithili" language to the language of only the Brahmins (the name of the artist who sketched the Vidyapati has still not been disclosed by this organisation). When these non-existent organizations exercise voting powers granted by Sahitya Akademi and chose a convener, it is not a coincidence that for successive times only conservative people among the Maithil Brahmin caste, are chosen. The complete list is:

1. Ramanath Jha

2. Jaykant Mishra

3. Surendra Jha Suman

4. Sureshwar Jha

5. Ramdeo Jha

6. Chandranath Mishra Amar

7. Vidyanath Jha Vidit

8. Veena Thakur

9. Prem Mohan Mishra

10. Ashok Avichal.

The result is now for everybody to see. The complete list of Sahitya Akademi awards (till 2019) is:

Total booty distribution- 50 times, Maithil Brahmins- 42 times, Kayasthas- 6 times, Rajpoots- 3 times; Others- 0 times !!! (now in 2021 Sh. Jagdish Prasad Mandal has been awarded this prize for his novel "Pangu", so the count is now not zero but one.

The result is not based on the quality of the books but solely upon the caste-based other considerations and the disease has its root in the faulty seedling that the Sahitya Akademi of India found through the faulty literary associations.

What were the objectives of the setting of this Akademi?

Sahitya Akademi was established (National Academy of Letters to be called Sahitya Akademi) by Government of India resolution No F-6-4/51G2(A) dated December 1952 "to set high literary standards, to foster and co-ordinate literary activities in all the Indian languages and to promote through them all the cultural unity of the country; to promote good taste and healthy reading habits, to keep alive the intimate dialogue among the various linguistic and literary zones and groups through seminars, lectures, symposia, discussions, readings and performances, to increase the pace of mutual translations through workshops and individual assignments and to develop a serious literary culture through the publications of journals, monographs, individual creative works of every genre, anthologies, encyclopedias, dictionaries, bibliographies, who's who of writers and histories of literature."

The Akademi boasts of publishing "one book every thirty hours" and holding "at least thirty seminars every year" at regional, national and international levels, " along with the workshops and literary gatherings-about 200 in number per year".

The Akademi recognises " Besides the twenty-two languages enumerated in the Constitution of India", English and Rajasthani as languages. 24 language Advisory Boards have been constituted by Sahitya Akademi "to render advice for implementing literary programmes in these 24 languages".

The Akademi gives prizes in 24 languages recognised by it for original and translated works. It gives " special awards called Bhasha Samman to a significant contribution to the languages not formally recognized by the Akademi as also for contribution to classical and medieval literature"; "It has also a system of electing eminent writers as Fellows and Honorary Fellows and has also established a fellowship in the names of Dr Anand Coomaraswamy and Premchand".

FESTIVAL OF LETTERS (SHAME)!!!!

In February every year, Sahitya Akademi "holds a week-long Festival of Letters; It begins with the ceremony to present the Akademi’s Annual Awards for creative writing".

In February every year, there is a need to examine whether Sahitya Akademi is fulfilling its objective and whether Sahitya Akademi is aware of the rich cultural and linguistic variety prevalent in India.

On scrutiny it is revealed that Sahitya Akademi believes in "forced standardisation of culture through a bulldozing of levels and attitudes" and it is not "conscious of the deep inner cultural, spiritual, historical and experiential links that unify India’s diverse manifestations of literature".

The Akademi boasts of publishing "one book every thirty hours" and holding "at least thirty seminars every year" at regional, national and international levels, "along with the workshops and literary gatherings-about 200 in number per year". If we see the data in respect of Maithili it comes out that every year around 12 books should have been published in Maithili and the Maithili writers might have attended 30 seminars every year at regional, national and international levels and might have participated in 8 literary gatherings every year. The number of Maithili books published by the Akademi is pathetically low, and when we see the assignments, through which these books get artificially prepared (be it translation, anthology or monograph), then the people getting these assignments are often related to the members of the advisory board (as the answer to RTI application by Sh. Vinit Utpal brings forth). The quality suffers, and as a result, there is no readership.

How this Akademi failed? And why this Akademi failed? And what action should be taken against Akademi for its intentional failure?

Firstly, Akademi is not the name of a man or woman. Akademi or its member of the Advisory Board consists of persons, and if the group of persons is failing the Akademi, that language itself is to blame! But again the language is not the name of a man or woman. So, the people speaking that language are to be blamed for the failures of the Akademi. Really!!

Even if it is partially true, the Sahitya Akademy cannot shirk its responsibilities. How an advisory committee can be considered representative of Maithili-speaking people (even that of India), when the Convener of that language is nominated by six organisations (recognised by the Sahitya Akademi for reasons best known to it), having no remote connection with literature? Sahitya Akademi sowed seeds of Acacia and expected Mango fruit. Having said that it is also true that the Akademi or any organisation can transform itself, but only when the conservative people representing these find pressure from the literary fraternity, change themselves or are replaced.

What is the solution?

The literary fraternity has already taken initiative by establishing parallel Sahitya Akademi awards and parallel literary meets. It should be taken further. All legal means should be explored to take the Akademi to the task. On all available forums, the fact is made clear that the literature being prepared by Sahitya Akademi through assignments is not grammatically correct, that it is not up to mark and is of inferior quality. On all available forums, it should be made clear that the thin, casteist-looking (quantitatively and qualitatively) and pale Maithili literature, that is being shown by the Sahitya Akademi of India to the world, has no readership or respect in its native speaking area of India and Nepal. And that Maithili has moved not because of Sahitya Akademi but despite it.

Demand

The six organisations representing Maithili should be derecognized with immediate effect and an inquiry initiated to ascertain their genuineness. A committee should be set up to scrutinize the work done by the Sahitya Akademi (in respect of Maithili) in the last 55 years. The awards should be kept in abeyance till the results of the inquiry are made public and corrective steps are taken.

2

THE CELEBRATION BEGINS

Videha Ist Maithili Fortnightly International e-journal has e-published more than 300 issues to date. Meanwhile, We will enumerate the problems faced and the solutions found by us. The Journey began in the year 2000 at yahoo Geocities- the first words on the internet in Maithili were written by me on the yahoo Geocities sites (now yahoo has discontinued Geocities) towards the end of 2000 when I suffered a major accident which kept me confined to crutches for nearly one and a half years. But that perhaps shaped my destiny. I could concentrate on my Maithili writings and my research on Tirhuta Manuscripts. On 5th July 2004, the first blog in Maithili came (gajendrathakur.blogspot.com) as "Bhalsarik Gachh", which was rechristened as Videha ejournal from 1st January 2008. From Ist January 2008 it came to be published as a fortnightly journal. The 1st rechristened issue brought the story of the life and creations of a forgotten Maithili poet Late Ramji Choudhary (1878-1952).

Till the eighth issue of Videha the columns on Music, Mithila Painting, Children column, Learn samskrit through Maithili got strengthened. Moreover, the projects on digitalisation of Maithili Classics and Panji Manuscript-leafs got started. The searchable dictionary (Maithili-English_Maithili) was designed and strengthened. From the eighth issue, a latest unpublished Maithili Play of Nachiketa "No Entry Maa Pravish" began its e-publication in Videha. Nachiketa, the greatest dramatist of Maithili Literature was silent for the last 25 years, so far as the drama was concerned.

Technology has two aspects, bad (its chances of misuse) and good (its good use). It is a great leveller, it challenges status quo forces. It is applicable in all areas of knowledge. So school-going children today have a more clear understanding of the universe and atoms than the Aryabhata or Sir Issac Newton had. After mass-scale use of printing education and literature expanded its wings, but only after the "Internet and electronic transformation of tools of knowledge", it has become universal, it has jumped geographical boundaries. All shackles unfurled, the weak links of the chain were identified, and the chain which tried to capture knowledge, which tried to thwart its expansion, started breaking down. And the greatest beneficiary became the Maithili Literature. What is Videha, nothing, it is only its commitment to the Maithili Language, that helped it expand its base, and Videha became the means that were able to bind together the Maithili-speaking areas in both parts of the boundary (India & Nepal). Videha gave Maithili a batch of committed writers and a batch of committed readers. It challenged the status quo and casteist forces. It challenged confused writers, who were using Maithili as a tool to ride the ladder of Hindi. The lack of criticism, the lack of teeth in criticism was the

reason that some writers and dramatists were using Hindi-Mix Maithili for cheap popularity, they were using derogatory language for the so-called lower castes of their society (some were finding plea in Natyashastra- when even the modern-day Samskrit Drama is not using Prakrit etc.!!), and for their mimicry, those castes started keeping distance with this kind of literature. And once the confusion of the confused thinned, a new type of awakened literature, stage and drama (top-class) became the norm.

Videha is getting regularly some excellent brains. Since its inception, Videha, the idea factory, is dependent upon them. So far as their versatile qualities are concerned, people associated with Videha are different. All are known for their perseverance and resilience. All are known for their hard work. All are known for their quality work. All are known for their discipline. And above all, all are committed; committed to Maithili and the Mithila. The cumulative force resulted in a natural revolution. A revolution in the field of Maithili Literature, art, music, craft, stage and drama. The only International e-journal in Maithili started this quality movement in Maithili. Nothing less than world standard was acceptable. The awards were instituted to recognize the parallel field of Maithili Literature, art, music, craft, stage and drama. Only the best were selected, there was no scope for the second best. The participation of readers in the decision-making processes was encouraged. The readers got full access to the digitalised Maithili Literature. More than 500 Maithili books and around 11000 palm-leaf mithilakshar manuscripts were digitalised and made available online under the "Videha Archive" section of www.videha.co.in (and the number is increasing every day). The audio-video-paintings-photographs were archived, and all these archived "art and lifestyle" of the people of Mithila were then placed online. The Videha Archive is a unique gift to the world.

So what is the ideology of people associated with Videha? Is it collective thinking? No, of course not. In Videha all are welcome. Here all are welcome to discuss their respective ideology. Having said this, it needs emphasis that there are some basic human principles where no compromise is possible. The casteists, those having genetic superiority complex (which is another name for an inferiority complex), the practitioners of plagiarism, those who are unable to take part in a healthy discussion and persons who are not able to withstand the criticism of their creation, Videha is not a platform for them. The ideology of people associated with Videha may have different tinges, not all need to toe the line taken by any member of the editorial board. Videha believes in the individuality of ideas and the editorial board never imposes its ideology upon its members. At the same time, it is being emphasized that each member of the

Videha editorial board has a strong ideological leaning, the ideology of humanism is practised by all.

Videha-Maithili Literature Movement has its roots in the year 2000 when I started making Maithili Websites on Yahoo Geocities. After Yahoo Closed Geocities these sites were automatically deleted. However the early form of Videha "Bhalsari Gachh" was started on 5 July 2004, and it is the earliest presence of Maithili on the internet. Videha and its vibrant members did their utmost in translating lacs of words on Wikipedia and they successfully opposed the nomenclature "Bihari Languages" (Gerard M accepted the role of Umesh Mandal, the co-editor of Videha, go to Gerard M's blog and click the Dasipat Aripan photo from Videha archive (Preeti Thakur) placed at his blog, you will reach http://videha.co.in/). In Google translate/Wikipedia localisation drive, in Tirhuta and Kaithi script research and the localisation of Braille in consonance with the Maithili Language, Videha shouldered the responsibility as a pioneer in technology viz-a-viz Maithili Language. It was a pioneer in many respects. It started for the first time a Maithili Websites Aggregator at http://videha-aggregator.blogspot.com/, the first braille site in Maithili, the first mithilakshar site in Maithili among others.

Videha has organised several dozen Maithili book fairs to date. The 16th Videha Maithili book fair was held at Sagar Rati Deep Jaray, Patna on 10-11th December 2011 and the 17th Videha Maithili book fair was held at Guwahati, on 22-23 December next year at the Vidyapati Parv organised by Mithila Sanskritik Samanvay Samiti. Videha also organised a parallel Sahitya Akademi Kavi Sammelan, besides awarding parallel Sahitya Akademi prizes, as corrective measures, as the awards and Kavi Sammellans of Sahitya Akademi were awarded/ organised in a unilateral manner where merit took a beating. Videha has, thus, fulfilled its obligation by interfering in the murky affairs of government organisations. Videha cannot remain a silent spectator, be it plagiarism or copyright violations. So the authors like Pankaj Parashar, and Ashok Sahu, who were engaged in lifting other articles/ stories/ poems were banned after verifying the sources and target writings.

Literature in translation is a major issue with Videha. Lack of translation in America resulted in Americans lagging in quality literature. We practise literature in translation in both directions- from Maithili into English and from other languages into Maithili. So far as translations from other languages into Maithili are concerned English, Nepali, Sanskrit and Hindi act as buffer languages in the process. Direct translations into Maithili are limited; and it is done directly only from English, Sanskrit, Hindi, Nepali and Bengali, although

there are some exceptions. So far as the question of translations from Maithili into other languages is concerned, directed translations are again limited; and it is again done directly only into English, Hindi, Sanskrit, Bengali and Nepali, barring some exceptions. Videha contacted some notable personalities of class literature, took permission and translated that literature into Maithili. Most of the time English was used as a buffer language and translation work from English, Hindi, Konkani, Telugu, Gujarati, Oriya, Kannada, Nepali and Telugu into Maithili was completed; and these works were regularly published in Videha. Maithili novels, poems and short stories, on the other hand, were translated from Maithili into English and were published regularly in Videha.

VIDEHA became a Maithili Literature movement. No, VIDEHA was from day one of the Maithili Literature movement. Many established misconceptions got cleared through VIDEHA. The well-known facts, the not-so-obvious plot of some people to kill Maithili through its twin institutions the Sahitya Akademi and the CIIL was unearthed. The Right to Information came in handy. Sri Vinit Utpal asked for information from Sahitya Akademi through his RTI application dated 23.09.2011 (file no. RTI-125) sought information on "Assignment assigned by Maithili Advisory Board, Sahitya Akademi under the convener ship of Sri Vidyanath Jha ‘Vidit’". The information included a proposal received, a proposal rejected and a proposal kept in abeyance."

Similarly reply dated 30.10.2014 of Sahitya Akademi [File No RTI/310/31517] on an application filed by Ashish Anchinhar under Right to Information Act, 2005, the Sahitya Akademi gave vague and incomplete reply. Still the partial statutory mandatory information supplied by the Sahitya Akademi unearthed a vicious circle of Maithili-speaking so-called litterateurs, hell-bent upon making Maithili a language- "of the Maithil Brahmin, for the Maithil Brahmin and by the Maithil Brahmin".

More than 90% of the assignments went to the friends, relatives and acquaintances of the 10-member Maithili Advisory Board. No assignment to Sh. Jagdish Prasad Mandal, Sh. Rajdeo Mandal, Sh. Bechan Thakur (the greatest Short-story-novel writer of Maithili, the greatest living poet of Maithili and the greatest living Maithili dramatist; respectively), Sh. Umesh Paswan, Sh. Umesh Mandal, Sh. Ramdev Prasad Mandal "Jharudar", Sh. Durganand Mandal, Sh. Sandeep Kumar Safi or to Sh. Anand Kumar Jha. When every member of the Maithili advisory board is hand in glove with the Sahitya Akademi to kill the Maithili language then where lies the hope? The demand for Mithila state by these people will see that 10 Maithil Brahmin families would loot the Mithila state. Then where lies the hope? Here lies hope. Sh. Bechan

Thakur has created a parallel Maithili stage and theatre, a slap on the existing slapstick humouristic Maithili theatre. Sh. Umesh Paswan is a discovery of the Parallel Sahitya Akademi Poetry festival organised by Videha. Sh. Jagdish Prasad Mandal, Sh. Rajdeo Mandal, Sh. Jharudar, Sh. Sandeep Kumar Safi and Sh Umesh Mandal have pumped their energy, wealth and time into our Maithili Language. This language will live...proofs are given below:-

Google translate

http://www.google.com/transconsole/giyl/chooseProject

then Wikipedia translate:

http://translatewiki.net/wiki/Special:Translate?
task=untranslated&group=core-mostused&limit=2000&language=mai

http://translatewiki.net/wiki/Project:Translator

http://translatewiki.net/wiki/Project:Translator
http://meta.wikimedia.org/wiki/Requests_for_new_languages/Wikipedia_Maithili

http://translatewiki.net/wiki/Special:Translate?
task=untranslated&group=core-mostused&limit=2000&language=mai
http://incubator.wikimedia.org/wiki/Wp/mai
http://translatewiki.net/wiki/MediaWiki:Mainpage/mai

http://ultimategerardm.blogspot.com/2011/05/bihari-wikipedia-is-actually-written-in.html )

[Monday, May 09, 2011

The Bihari Wikipedia is written in Bhojpuri

This is the kind of article that has many people’s eyes glazed over. It is about standards and scientific documents and it is about languages most of my readers have never heard about. For the people that do speak one of the languages that are considered Bihari, it is extremely relevant and it has implications for Wikipedia.

This is information provided by Umesh Mandal that explains the "Bihari group of languages" with the Maithili language:

Kellogg (1876/1893) and Hoernle (1880) regarded Maithili as a dialect of Eastern Hindi; Beames (1872/reprint 1966: 84-85), regarded Maithili as a dialect of Bengali, Grierson has done a great service to the Maithili language, however, he erred when he gave a false notional term of "Bihari" language after

that western linguists started categorizing Maithili as a dialect of "Bihari" language; although there is nothing known as "Bihari Language" and both Maithili and Bhojpuri are spoken in Bihar (of India) as well as in Nepal.

Umesh is working on the localisation of MediaWiki for the Maithili language and as this language is currently in the Incubator, the language committee does its due diligence and trying to understand if Maithili can have a place in the Bihari Wikipedia. The information provided by Umesh makes it quite clear: "no".

This still leaves us with the misnomer that is the Bihari Wikipedia. The language used for the localisation and the articles is Bhojpuri. Bhojpuri has the ISO-639-3 code "bho".

Are you still following all this? Ok, there is one question I am not asking: How about the Kaithi script?

Thanks, GerardM]

Excerpt from a Maithili e-journal published as PDF (from Videha 2011: 22; Videha: A fortnightly Maithili e-journal. Issue 80 (April 15, 2011), Gajendra Thakur [ed]. http://www.videha.co.in/ ."Gajendra Thakur of New Delhi graciously met with me and corresponded at length about Maithili, offered valuable specimens of Maithili manuscripts, printed books, and other records, and provided feedback regarding requirements for the encoding of Maithili in the UCS."-Anshuman Pandey.] ।

TIRHUTA UNICODE See the final UNICODE Mithilakshara Application (May 5, 2011) by Sh. Anshuman Pandey at Page 23 of the Videha 80th issue (Tirhuta version) is attached"Figure 11: Excerpt from a Maithili e-journal published as PDF (from Videha 2011: 22" and at Page 12 Videha is included in References Videha: A fortnightly Maithili e-journal. Issue 80 (April 15, 2011), Gajendra Thakur [ed]. http://www.videha.co.in/. and role of Videha's editor is acknowledged on Page 12 "Gajendra Thakur of New Delhi graciously met with me and corresponded at length about Maithili, offered valuable specimens of Maithili manuscripts, printed books, and other records, and provided feedback regarding requirements for the encoding of Maithili in the UCS." ]

The Maithili Speaking area is shrinking. It is shrinking due to a conscious-subconscious policy of the Governments of India and Nepal, and the situation became critical due to the invasion of Hindi and Nepali media and the biased educational system in Maithili-speaking areas, and also due to the large-scale migration that has happened in one single generation. The question of Hindi

saw to it that Vajjika, Angika and now Thethi, Surjapuri etc. languages should get the tacit support of supporters of Hindi, first in the name of religion and second in the name of caste. Through this they did not support Vajjika, Angika, Thethi or Surjapuri; but they tried to weaken Maithili, which ultimately resulted in the weakening of Vajjika, Angika, Thethi and Surjapuri. For all this, the Maithili-speaking people, more so the officials (I will explain it later on), are also responsible, as they tried to delimit Maithili within the two castes and four districts. All other people and areas, than these, were considered northern, southern, eastern and western deviations of so-called pure Maithili, which was fictitiously considered as being spoken by these Maithil Brahmins/ Karna Kayasthas of Madhubani, Darbhanga, Saharsa and Supaul districts. For the last 45 years the officials, yes I call them officials, the officials of the Maithili Department of Sahitya Akademi, did not try to accommodate the people outside this fictitiously delimited domain. But the major problem lies somewhere else. The slow poisoning was given in many disguises, be it the faulty top-heavy education system, which neglected primary and middle school education through the Mother Language Maithili, or be it through the concept of dialect, which initially conveniently declared languages like Maithili as dialects. Elementary education through Maithili was a non-starter because the Maithili books published by the Bihar State Textbook Publishing Corporation Limited seemed to be in Avahatt, it was not fit for children. Further, the authors and subjects selected for these books had a casteist bias. Maithili became a tool for caste-based politics, as once Hindi had been a tool for religion-based politics. Still, these officials, of the Maithili Department of Sahitya Akademi, are residing in their own built ghetto, bereft of any thinking or vision. Another reason for the present plight of Maithili is the policy undertaken by the tax collectors of Mithila (permanent settlement Zamindars of Cornwallis), whom the sycophants call King or the great king (Raja/ Maharaja) or Mithilesh (King of Mithila) these were mere tax collectors, the right for which were given to the highest bidders permanently; and there was not one such Mithilesh (tax collectors), but many within the borders of Mithila. These tax collectors employed mostly those two castes from four districts in their merchandise venture, and as the selection was based on sycophancy, so the work suffered. So they imported the lathiyals from outside the Mithila region. The masses of Mithila suffered a blow from the double-edged weapon. First, from their people who did not consider them as their own and second they got looted by the outsiders. Now after some time these outsiders, the non-Maithili speaking people, found it convenient to declare the masses (not belonging to the two castes from four districts) as non-Maithili speaking people, and the officials/

sycophants from those two castes from four districts tacitly agreed to it. Now these outsiders, the non-Maithili speaking people, formed a majority in many places of Mithila, and they led the rumour that Maithili, like Samskrit, is an upper-caste phenomenon, and thus they legitimized their anti-Maithili stance (all these facts have been brilliantly dealt with in the Maithili Novels of Sh. Jagdish Prasad Mandal) and they propagated the case of Hindi, first based on religion and second based on caste. But why our people fell into their trap, why these tax-collector Maharajas did not consider the masses of Mithila as their own and imported the perpetrators to loot their masses? The simple answer is that merit took a downward leap in auction-based tax collection rights allocation.

We started from one and reached number three, then thirty and now three hundred!! and we are growing-... and are 300 not out, and are creating a grand history. http://www.videha.co.in/ Videha Ist Maithili Fortnightly e-Journal ISSN 2229-547X has e-published its 300th issue recently. When I began this venture in the year 2000 with a Samsung TV net appliance, and when the existing was posted on 5th of July 2004, I moved all alone. Then on 31st January 2007, I suddenly thought to include the public, as after some groundwork I was ready for it. I decided to e-publish Videha and did publish it, on a fortnightly basis, the first issue that came on 1st January 2008 tried to include all the previous posts.

From all corners of this planet earth, the people tried to change the destiny of Mithila and Maithili. Now Sh. Ashish Anchinhar, Sh. Munnaji (Manoj Kumar Karn), are part of our team; and together we are 300 not out now. With 300 plus issues, 30,000 pages of Maithili literature (100 lac words corpora) creation and 11000 Tirhuta manuscript transcription we maintained a 50000-word Maithili-English vocabulary database. Now we are 350 strong, with 350 authors.

Videha has faced challenges and has withstood them. We never shirk from any question and/ or problem. The question of the state of Mithila is one such question which often comes calling. We are in favour of the states of Mithila within the sovereign borders of India and Nepal. We are in favour of Mithila. But which type of Mithila, that type that we had during the Zamindari Raj, where means of sustenance and avenues of existence remained limited for a few castes? Or that culture that existed within "Aryavarta-Indian Nation newspaper" and other Industries during that Raj. All of these got galloped by a dozen families of Mithila mostly from a single caste!! No, we are not in support of that Mithila, that Mithila where Maithili would be swallowed, as it is being swallowed by the Sahitya Akademi and the CIIL, swallowed by another dozen

families. We are not in favour of that Mithila where the proceeding of the legislative assembly would be held in a language other than Maithili. Till the misgivings of the people of Mithila are addressed, we cannot support any Mithila state movement. So the people striving hard for Mithila state should sit on a protest before the advisory board members of the Sahitya Akademi/ CIIL and sing patriotic songs in front of their houses, and pressurise them not to misuse government funds by unscrupulously awarding functions of Akademi outside Mithila and not to misuse the power of assigning translation and other rights to themselves and to those people who are hell-bent upon destroying our language. The RTI application by Sh. Vinit Utpal has thwarted an attempt to strangulate Maithili, but if the supplementary work is not done the sinister design would resurface again. We request the Maithili advisory board members of Sahitya Akademi immediately return their assignments taken in their name and the name of the members of their family. Otherwise, pressure should be mounted to force these 10-member Maithili Advisory Board members to voluntarily resign from their membership in the larger interest of Maithili. So what is our answer viz-a-viz demand of Mithila state: it's a categorical Yes.

The technology-centric venture called Videha became a success. The native speakers of Maithili reside in Bihar (of India) and South-East Nepal. The net connectivity had been very poor in these areas. Then how the authors, new and old, started using Unicode for writing for Videha. The Nepal Side of Mithila had been using Preeti, Kantipur, Himala etc. fonts, the Kolkata Maithili-speaking population had been using the Marathi fonts and the rest had been using the fonts based on the old Remington keyboard. All these three types of fonts are ASCII fonts. We researched these fonts and provided font converters to our Nepal-based authors. We also provided phonetic and Remington-based Unicode writers to all Maithili authors, who asked for them. We asked the authors if they may send their creations in any font, but at the same time, we encouraged them to use Unicode fonts. The technical support that we provided resulted in numerous receipts of typed entries from persons like Sh. Gangesh Gunjan, who in earlier stages had been sending their creations in their handwritings. As Sh. Gangesh Gunjan was well versed in Remington keyboard typing, so he made great use of the Remington Unicode typewriter. He sent that software to some of his friends too and he was courteous enough to intimate about this to us, although there was no need for that. Sh. Saketanand also used that software and sent his short-story कालरात्रिश्च दारुणा in Unicode, and it was published in one of the issues of Videha. The technology-centric venture called Videha became a success because we made it simple and intelligible at a time

when even the technologists were not sure about the future of this Unicode. The virtual medium was being seen with anxiety by the literary fraternity, and the copy-paste system of theft was rampant in those days. But we assured the authors that with Videha they may rest assured that the copyright thieves would not be spared, while at the same time we were firm, that only for fear of misuse of technology we should not stop our venture midway. With the internet and technology, the geographic barrier became non-existing. The end of the problem of distribution in Maithili literature became possible due to our technology-friendly attitude and it proved a boon for our Maithili language. And it made the technology-centric venture called Videha a success... It is the success of the parallel Maithili literature movement.

The references to parallel literature are found in Vedas, where Narashanshi is referred to as parallel literature.

Parallel Literature in Maithili

The need for parallel literature in Maithili arose due to the constant onslaught on literature and dignity by the Public and Private Academies, for example, Maithili-Bhojpuri Akademi of Delhi, Maithili Akademi of Patna, Sahitya Akademi of Delhi, Nepal's Prajna Pratishthan, all of which are government Academies. In addition to these Academies, the onslaught on Maithili Literature and dignity was constantly done by the so-called literary associations which were recognised by the Sahitya Akademi and were the main tool for usurping all the literary space meant for this language. Besides these, the funding to these and other parochial associations and organisations led to the presentation of an interface in the name of Maithili, which was mediocre and non-representative.

## VIDEHA MAITHILI LITERATURE MOVEMENT AND A PARALLEL HISTORY OF MAITHILI LITERATURE

Therefore, the missing portions, the ignored and non-represented aspects of society, started to be chronicled. It led to the depiction marked by the richness of vocabulary and experiences and was a revolution in literature and art as far as people speaking Maithili are concerned. The quality now has not remained

mediocre. The real power of the Maithili language was realised by the native speakers, mediocrity was replaced by excellence. This attempt at the writing of History of Parallel Literature for the Maithili Language arose as the mediocre agency (private and governmental) funded so-called mainstream literature, which has no readership, and no acceptance among the speakers of Maithili continued to be presented by these Akademies as representative literature. Literary journals like Museindia (www.museindia.com ) were also used for their sinister design. The mediocre interface of Maithili literature was presented by the government radio and television stations also.

## ERA BEFORE AND AFTER: LITERARY SCENE IN MAITHILI AFTER THE ARRIVAL OF JAGDISH PRASAD MANDAL

Amartya Sen wrote about the famine of Bengal (1942-43), talking about how lacs and lacs of people died in that famine (15 lacs as per estimates of the Famine Enquiry Commission), but that this didn't include his loved ones. Likewise in 1967, there happened a great famine in Mithila. When Indira Gandhi (then the Prime Minister of India) visited the area, she was shown how the people from the Mushhar community survived simply by eating bisarh (roots of lotus and other plants).

But this tragedy was written about only in 2009 by Sh. Jagdish Prasad Mandal, over forty years after it happened. And the reasons for that delay are obvious. In Maithili literature, there is a lopsided tendency which has made its journey slanted and ugly. The ones writing for mainstream Maithili literature have had no firsthand experience of tragedies of this magnitude, so they could never write on such subjects.

The coming of Jagdish Prasad Mandal on the literary scene simultaneously started a renaissance and a reformation movement in Maithili literature. It commenced a shiny new era. He gets credit for correcting the dark and ugly course the literary scene had taken. He gets credit for filling the gap and correcting the lopsided course of Maithili literature, which was hitherto moving on a one-way road.

Jagdish Prasad Mandal is an artist. He can convey the facts in such an amazing way that the reader is left in a trance.

He can present the facts directionally and purposefully. Armed with this ability he has defined the literature of the Maithili language so greatly that we could bifurcate its history into two eras: the era before Jagdish Prasad Mandal, and the era which comes after.

His facts are collated from every section of society. They're not placed in his prose as ornaments. Instead, they flow naturally.

It's as if a high tide has shaken the coastlines of the so-called main drain of Maithili literature, which dies completely but then regains its shape during the monsoon.

His words never present a lament. His writing never shirks from its responsibilities. No matter what hardships they face, the characters never lose hope or blame their lack of resources; they never grow dismal and resolutely keep marching on.

He has respect for the lifestyles and contributions of every stratum of society, and that is very exceptional. This becomes effective because there is no mismatch between his words and his deeds, and this is because of the greatness of his personal and social life. What he thinks, what he does, and what he writes. It makes his literature truthful.

The ups and downs of the lyrical voice of the Maithili language attracted even the great Yehudi Menuhin who, in a BBC programme, said it was one of the sweetest languages. He talked of how his entire body swung hearing this language. Jagdish Prasad Mandal uses the ups and downs of this lyrical/rhythmic language to show the affinity of mutual dependence with its society and culture.

This will bring revolution not only in literature but also in the economic arena.

*Genealogical records kept in Mithila suggest that he had a wife and three sons and a daughter. One child was the famous Nyaya author, Vardhamana. Gangesa apparently achieved quite some fame during his lifetime, referred to as "jagad-guru," which would be the rough equivalent of "Distinguished University Professor" for the educational institutions of his time.*

*[Phillips, Stephen, "Gangesa", The Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy (Summer 2020 Edition), Edward N. Zalta (ed.), URL = https://plato.stanford.edu/archives/sum2020/entries/gangesa/ ]*

"Gangesha Upadhyaya was the Jagadguru (Universal Teacher), but he was also the **Paramguru** (Supreme Teacher). Aside from him, the title of Paramguru

was only later conferred upon Nutan Vachaspati (the successor of Vriddha Vachaspati).

However, the injustice done to Gangesha by Ramanath Jha and Udaynath Jha 'Ashok' occurred in the 20th and 21st centuries, the adverse consequences of which logicians like **Stephen Phillips** were cursed to endure.

It should be noted here that Stephen Phillips is the first person to have completed a full English translation of all four volumes of the **Tattvachintamani**."

[Jewel of Reflection on the Truth about Epistemology: A Complete and Annotated Translation of the Tattva-cinta-mani, Bloomsbury Academic (2020)]।

"**V.P. Bhatta** has also completed the full translation of all four volumes of the **Tattvachintamani** as of 2025: [(1) *Pratyaksha* (Perception), (2) *Anumana* (Inference), (3) *Upamana* (Comparison), and (4) *Shabda* (Verbal Testimony/Word)]."[Word The Sabdakhanda of Tattva Cintamani (2 Vols Set) 2005; Perception The Pratyaksa Khanda of The Tattva Cintamani 2012 (2 Vols Set); Inference the Anumana Khanda of the Tattva Cintamani (2 Vols Set) 2021 & Inference of God and Comparison The Isvaranumana and The Upamana Khanda of The Tattva Cintamani (2 Vols Set) 2025 [by V. P. Bhatta with Introduction, Sanskrit Text, Translation And Explanation; Published by Eastern Book Linkers, Delhi].

**HONOUR KILLING OF GANGESH UPADHYAYA (FIRST BY RAMANATH JHA, THEN BY UDAYANATH JHA 'ASHOK'** *(A PARALLEL HISTORY OF MITHILA AND MAITHILI LITERATURE, WHY TODAY ITS NEED BEING FELT MORE INTENSELY?)*

I was not surprised, though I must have been when I saw a monograph on Gangesh Upadhyaya, whose copyright is being held by Sahitya Akademi, the author of the monograph is Udayanath Jha ' Ashok'. I thought that Udayanath Jha ' Ashok', who has been given Bhasha Samman also, by the same Sahitya Akademi, would do some justice. But truth and research seem elusive in Sahitya Akademi monographs, at least that I found in this monograph.

I searched and searched through chapters, that now the author will show courage. But the author like Ramanath Jha seems ashamed of the roots and offspring of Gangesh Upadhyaya. He tries to confuse the issue, but there is no confusion now at least since 2009. But in 2016 Sahitya Akademi seems to carry out the casteist agenda. Udayanath Jha mockingly pretends to search his name,

lineage etc, where nothing is there to search for, yet he could not muster the courage, to tell the truth, and ends up just repeating the facts in 2016 that Dineshchandra Bhattacharya already has published way back in 1958.

The honour killing of Gangesh Upadhyaya by Prof. Ramanath Jha is being taken forward by Sahitya Akademi, Delhi in a most hypocritical way.

Ramanath Jha's obscurantism *vis-a-vis* Panji is evident from one example. The inter-caste marriage in Panji was well known to him (but he chose to keep the Dooshan Panji secret- which has been released by us in 2009), and it was apparent that the great navya-nyaya philosopher Gangesh Upadhyaya married a "Charmkarini" and was born five years after the death of his father (see our Panji Books Vol I & II available at http://videha.co.in/pothi.htm ). Sh. Dinesh Chandra Bhattacharya writes in the "History of Navya-Nyaya in Mithila". (1958)

"*The family which was inferior in social status is now extinct in Mithila--Gangesha's family is completely ignored and we are not expected to know even his father's name--...As there is no other reference to Gangesa we can assume that the family dwindled into insignificance again and became extinct soon after his son's death.*" [1958, Chapter III pages 96-99), which is a total falsehood. He writes further that all this information was given to him by Prof. R. Jha, and he seemed thankful to him.

The following excerpt from Our Panji Prabandh (parts I&II) is being reproduced below for ready reference:

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"**Maharaja Harasimhadeva** belonged to the **Karnat dynasty** of Mithila. In Jyotirishwar Thakur's *Varna-Ratnakara*, Harasimhadeva was portrayed as the hero or king. Born in 1294 AD, he ascended the throne in 1307 AD. Following his defeat by **Ghiyasuddin Tughlaq** in 1324–25 AD, he fled to Nepal.

He was the official founder of the **Panji-Prabandha** (the genealogical record system) among the Brahmins, Kayasthas, and Kshatriyas of Mithila. For this purpose, Gunakar Jha for the Maithil Brahmins, Shankardatt for the Karna Kayasthas, and Vijaydatt for the Kshatriyas were the first to be appointed.

Inspired by Harasimhadeva-who was a descendant of **Nanyadeva**, the founder of the Karnat dynasty in 1019 Shaka (as noted in the verse *Nanda-Indu-Shunya-Shashi Shaka Varshe* i.e., 1019 Shaka)-the scholars of Mithila decided to initiate the current form of the Panji-Prabandha in **1248 Shaka (1326 AD)**.

Later, in the current era, some intellectually driven individuals influenced **Mithilesh Maharaja Madhav Singh** in 1760 AD to order the *Panjikars* (genealogists) to compile the *Shakha Pustaks* (branch books). Following this (sometimes described as 1600 Shaka or 1678 AD, but actually around 1800 AD after Madhav Singh's time), a new Brahmin sub-caste named **Shrotriya** emerged in Mithila."

**So, the Srotriyas as a sub-caste arose around 1800 CE as per authentic panji files.** *Sh. Anshuman Pandey [Gajendra Thakur of New Delhi provided me with digitized copies of the genealogical records of the Maithil Brahmins. The panjikara-s whose families have maintained these records for generations are often reluctant to allow others to pursue their records. It is a matter of 'intellectual property' to them. I was fortunate enough to receive a complete digitized set of panji records from Gajendra Thakur of New Delhi in 2007. [Recasting the Brahmin in Medieval Mithila: Origins of Caste Identity among the Maithil Brahmins of North Bihar by Anshuman Pandey, A dissertation submitted in partial fulfilment of the requirements for the degree of Doctor of Philosophy (History) in the University of Michigan 2014].*

Later these Panji Manuscripts were uploaded to Videha Pothi at **www.videha.co.in** and google books in 2009).

The so-called Maharajas of Darbhanga were permanent settlement zamindars of Cornwallis, and there were so many in British India, but in Nepal there were none. In the annexure of our book (Panji Prabandh vol I&II), we have attached copies of genealogy-based upgradation orders (proof of upgradation for cash). So, before 1800 CE, there was no srotriya sub-caste in British India and there is no such sub-caste within Maithil Brahmins in Nepal part of Mithila even today. Srotriya before that referred to following some education stream in British India, in Nepal it still has that meaning.

**ORIGINAL PANJI REFERENCES ARE PLACED BELOW:**

**DOOSHAN PANJI- THE BLACKBOOK**
[https://ia601402.us.archive.org/31/items/maithili_202209/Gajendra_Thakur_Dooshan_Panji_The_Black_Book.pdf]

1

| | | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Sarisav 178/2 | Valiyas Chamru maternal village of | sarisav | Sakradhi | Panichobh | Darihara | Pali | Narwal |

| | | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| | Gangadhar | | | | | | |
| Bhavnath | | Nathu | Gangu | Kanh | Helu | Horai | Chand |
| Kamalnayan Kishai | Unknown 238//05 | Visho | Goge | Rud | Chand | Maternal Village of Ram | Deodhar |

**Table (1-97) of the Dooshan Panji, The Black Book by Gajendra Thakur;2023] Explanation of Example 1:**

"**Gunawati Himsha** [**Gunawati Himsha** in Dooshan (impure secret book) Panji (geneology book)] belonged to a different caste (*Aan Jatik*); her marriage took place with **Chamaru** of the **Valiyasa** Mool, and from this union, a son named **Gangadhar** was born. His daughter was married to **Nathu** of the **Sarisav** Mool, and they had a son named **Visho**. Furthermore, Visho's daughter married **Gangu** of the **Sakaradhi** Mool, resulting in a son named **Goge**.

Goge's daughter married **Kanhu** of the **Panichobh** Mool, and they had a son named **Rud** (Rudra). Rud's daughter married **Helu** of the **Darihara** Mool, and they had a son named **Chand**. Chand's daughter married **Horai** of the **Pali** Mool, resulting in a son named **Ram**-though the maternal details (*Matrik*) of Ram are unknown.

The offspring (daughter) of Ram then married **Chand** of the **Narwal** Mool. Their son, **Devadhar**, became **completely pure** (*Purnatah Shuddha*) in the **sixth generation**."

**49**

| | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| *188/2* | *Charmakarini* (from the *Charmakar* clan) | Mandar | Babhaniyam | Chhadan |
| Gangesha, the author of *Tattvachintamani*. | Chaadan Gangeshak | Nain | *Ratnakar's Maternal root* | Gangesha |

| | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | | *unknown* | |
| | Vallabha | Bhavai | Maheshwar | |
| | | | Jive | |

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| | | | | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Charmakarini | Sodarpur | Alay | Mandar | Naraun | Panichobh | Khandvala | Deeh Darihara | Brahmpur | Koraai |
| Medha | Shankar | Gadu | Afel | Mushe | Vidyapati | Ratnakar | Matikar | Mangu | Mandar |
| *189/1* | Govind | Shrinath | Vasudev | Jadu | Ramapati | *Surpati's mother [Charmkarini]* | | | Gangu-Medha |

**This text is a significant genealogical record from the Maithil Brahmin Panji (ancient scrolls) concerning the family of Gangesha Upadhyaya, the founder of the *Navya-Nyaya* (New Logic) school of Indian philosophy.**

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**"Record 21//10: From the Chhadan Mool (lineage) comes Jagadguru Gangesha, the author of *Tattvachintamani*.**

**From the Chhadan root, the wife (*Vallabha*) of Gangesha, the author of *Tattvachintamani*, was Charmakarini. It is recorded that Gangesha, the author of *Tattvachintamani*, was born five years after the passing of his father (*Pitri Parokshe Panch Varsh Vyatite*); he was the offspring of the lineage connected with Charmakarini Medha.**

**From the Chhadan root, Mahamahopadhyaya (M.M.) Gangesha, the author of *Tattvachintamani*.**

**'Information regarding Mahamahopadhyaya (M.M.) Gangesha, the author of *Tattvachintamani*, is available from the Ancient Panji.'"**

**"Gangesha was born five years after the passing (absence) of his father- this is an ancient scribal note found in some places."[**"Pitri parokshe panch

varsh vyatite Gangeshotpattiḥ iti prāchīn lekhaniyaḥ kutrāpi"- In Dooshan (impure secret) Panji]

**Devānand Pañjī 39-2:** "Chhādan-sañ Jagadguru Guru Gaṅgeś sutāy Babhaniyām-sañ Jayāditya sut Sādhukar patnī."

**Devānand Pañjī 339-3:** "Jagadguru Gaṅgeś sut Supan dau Bhaṇḍārisam-sañ Harāditya dau. Putra sutā-cha Gorā Jajivāl sañ Jīve patnī e sut Sandagahi Bhaveśvar. Atrāsthāne Supan-bhrātṛ Hariśarmma dāriti kvachit Jajivāl grām."

"Chhādan-sañ Tattva Chintāmaṇi kāraka Gaṅgeśak Vallabhā Charmakāriṇī pitṛ parokṣe pañca varṣa vyatīte Tattva Chintāmaṇi kāraka Gaṅgeśotpatti"["Charmakāriṇī Medhāk santānak lāgime chalanhi"]

"Tattva Chintāmaṇi kāraka Ma. Ma. Pā. Gaṅgeśak viṣayak lekh prāchīn pañjī-sañ upalabdh"

**Devānand Pañjī 339-3:** "Devānand Pañjī 339-3 Jagadguru Gaṅgeś sut Supan dau Bhaṇḍārisam-sañ Harāditya dau. Putra sutā-cha Gorā Jajivāl-sañ Jīve patnī e sut Sandagahi Bhaveśvar. Atrāsthāne Supan-bhrātṛ Hariśarmma dāriti kvachit Jajivāl grām."

**Devānand Pañjī 30-5:** "Devānand Pañjī 30-5 Chhādan-sañ Upāyakāraka Ma.Ma. Pā. Varddhamān sutā-cha Khaṇḍavalā-sañ Viśvanāth sut Śivanāth patnī Gaṅgeś-Ma.Ma. Varddvamān / Supan / Hariśarmma."

"Record 21//10: Jagadguru Gangesha, the author of *Tattvachintamani*, from the Chhadan lineage."

"Mahaprabhu. Gangesha Upadhyaya-Chhadan (Mool), Chhadan (Gram). Udayanacharya-Nanautivar (Mool), Nanauti (Gram) [Kariyan, Samastipur]."

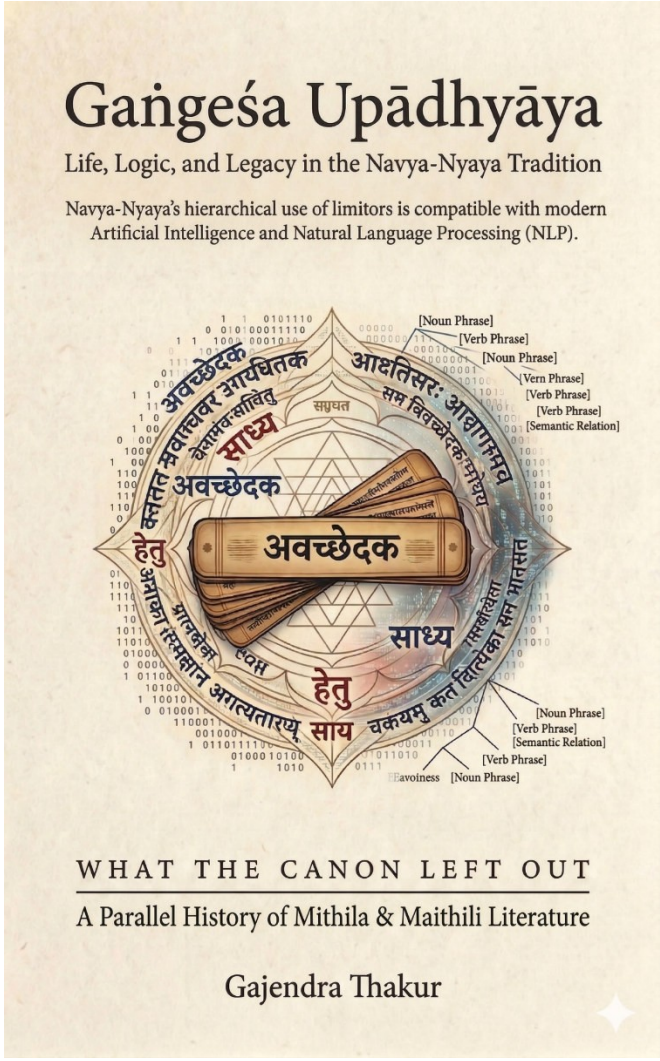
"Jajivāl-sañ Sandagahi Bhaveśvar Chhādan-sañ Tattva Chintāmaṇi kāraka Gaṅgeś sut Supan dau Jallakī-sañ Sādā Mahidhar 341."

Gangesh, the author of the Tattvachintamani, wrote one text equivalent to 12,000 texts. Now come to the fact mentioned in the Panji- it clearly states that Gangesh of Tattvachintamani was born five years after the death of his father and he married a tanner, so why did Ramanath Jha hide this from Dinesh Chandra Bhattacharya? Vardhamana, son of Gangesh, calls Gangesh *sukavikairavakananenduh*. But the conspiracy under which the poems of a famous scholar like Gangesh are not available today is clear from the example given above. Vasudev of Bengal was a classmate of Pakshadhar Mishra of Mithila, he came to study in Mithila, passed the *shalaka* examination and received the title of *sarvabhaum*. Vasudeva memorised

the *tattvachintamani* of Gangesh and the *nyayakusumanjali karika* of Udayana. Pakshadhar and other Mithila teachers did not allow writing (copying) *tattvachintamani*. Raghunath Shiromani, a disciple of Vasudeva, took the right of certification after he defeated his guru Pakshadhar Mishra in a scriptural debate *(shastrartha)*. The *Navya Nyaya* school was founded in Navadvipa by Vasudeva-Raghunath. Pakshadhar Mishra was a contemporary of Vidyapati (distinct from the Padavali writer who was of the pre-Jyotirishwar period) who wrote in Sanskrit and Avahatta. And the arrival of Mithila students of Bengal from Bengal stopped after Raghunath Shiromani. Gangesh Upadhyaya enjoyed *'param guru'* as well as *'jagad guru'* titles, the highest titles of the time and as per Panji only Vacaspati Mishra II was the other person who enjoyed the title of *'param guru'*. The extinction of Navya-Nyaya School from Mithila, as described above, was a revenge of nature against the honour killing of Gangesh Upadhyaya and his family.

*[Translation of the Maithili Short Story, 'Shabdashastram' (based on the true Panji records of Gangesh Upadhyaya) was done by the author Gajendra Thakur himself: published as 'The Science of Words' Indian Literature Vol. 58, No. 2 (280) (March/April 2014), pp. 78-93 (16 pages) Published By: Sahitya Akademi]*

**LESSON 002 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**




# GANGESA UPADHYAYA

Life, Logic, and Legacy in the Navya-Nyaya Tradition

Navya-Nyaya's hierarchical use of limitors is compatible with modern Artificial Intelligence and Natural Language Processing (NLP).

## LIFE, CONTEXT, AND THE CONTESTED LEGACY

Introduction: A Philosopher from Mithila

The land of Mithila has been one of the most continuously productive centres of Sanskrit intellectual culture in Asia. Here King Janaka's court was the scene of the philosophical dialogues of the Brhadaranyaka Upanisad; here Yajnavalkya, Gautama, and KatyayanaKātyāyana — names central to both the Nyāya-sūtra tradition and to Vedic grammar — are assigned Maithila origins and carry Maithili associations; here the poet Vidyapati sang in Maithili the songs that made a vernacular literature great; here the astronomer-mathematician Āryabhaṭa drew his early intellectual breath. It is in this milieu — prolific, disputatious, deeply scholastic — that Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya composed the work that changed the face of Indian philosophy. In the early fourteenth century, Gangesa Upadhyaya composed the Tattvacintamani — the Thought-Jewel of Truth — a work that permanently transformed the intellectual landscape of India. The Tattva-Cintāmaṇi (literally "Thought-Jewel of Truth", also known as Pramāṇa-cintāmaṇi or simply Cintāmaṇi), "Thought-Jewel of Valid Knowledge") is Gaṅgeśa's single great surviving work. It is a Pramāṇa-śāstra — a treatise on the means of valid knowledge — divided into four books: (1) Pratyakṣa-khaṇḍa (Perception), (2) Anumāna-khaṇḍa (Inference), (3) Upamāna-khaṇḍa (Comparison/Analogy), and (4) Śabda-khaṇḍa (Verbal Testimony). The Tattva-Cintāmaṇi is Gaṅgeśa's only surviving work and one of the most commented-upon texts in the Sanskrit tradition. By abandoning the exhaustive all-category coverage of earlier Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika writing and restricting himself exclusively to the pramāṇas — the sources of valid knowledge — Gaṅgeśa gave the tradition a sharply new focus and a correspondingly new name. All Nyāya literature written before his time is called prācīna-nyāya (Old Logic); everything from his work forward is navya-nyāya (New Logic). This periodisation, though simplistic, captures a genuine qualitative shift: in vocabulary, in method, in the level of analytical precision, and in the displacement of all older commentaries by the Tattva-Cintāmaṇi as the single central text of the school.

While Gangesha is the consolidator of this school, the real founder of the methodology he perfected was the 11th-century polymath Udayanācārya, whose Pariśuddhi and Kusumāñjali provided the threshold that rang out the ancient Nyaya age. Modern academic consensus, including the Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, identifies Gangesha as a "Great Professor" (mahôpādhyāya) from the kingdom of Mithila.

In mainstream Indian philosophical historiography, Gangesa Upadhyaya is revered as the undisputed architect of Navya-Nyaya. In his Hindi monograph,

भारतीय साहित्य के निर्माता: गंगेश उपाध्याय, Udayanath Jha 'Ashok' dates Gangesa to approximately 1300–1350 CE. Jha paints a picture of a scholar who earned the prestigious title of 'Mahamahopadhyaya'—a designation strictly reserved in Mithila for philosophers possessing unparalleled mastery over Nyaya, Mimamsa, and Dharmashastra.

Similarly, Dinesh Chandra Bhattacharya's History of Navya Nyaya in Mithila traces the intellectual lineage of Mithila, mapping the evolution from the ancient Prameya-focused (ontological) Nyaya of Gautama to the Pramana-focused (epistemological) rigor of Gangesa.

A critical discrepancy emerges when cross-referencing these sanitized orthodox accounts with the Dooshan Panji (the genealogical records of "flaws" or social infractions in Mithila), as extensively documented in the Videha parallel history research.

The Dooshan Panji reveals two explosive biographical details about Gangesa Upadhyaya:

Birth Anomaly: Gangesa was born five years after the death of his recognized father.

Unorthodox Marriage: He married a Charmkarini (a woman from the leather-tanning caste).

The Historiographical "Honour-Killing" of Truth

The discrepancy between the mainstream texts and the Dooshan Panji is not accidental; it is an active historiographical suppression. Prof. Ramanath Jha, a central figure in modern Maithili Panji systematization, is noted in the parallel history archives for suppressing these specific Dooshan Panji records.

Because Gangesa elevated Mithila to the undisputed capital of Indian logic, acknowledging his "illegitimate" birth and out-of-caste marriage threatened the Brahminical purity narratives of the era. Consequently, orthodox historians engaged in what the parallel history terms an "honour-killing of his legacy." Udayanath Jha's recent monograph continues this tradition of omission, focusing entirely on Gangesa's Sanskrit titles and philosophical prestige while ignoring the socio-historical realities of his marginalized personal background. Recognizing this suppression is vital for modern scholarship, as it frames Gangesa not just as an elite logician, but as a brilliant mind who transcended immense societal ostracization.

THE TRANSITION TO NAVYA-NYAYA:The Paradigm Shift: From Prameya to Pramana

As Karl H. Potter notes in the Encyclopedia of Indian Philosophies (Vol. 6), classical Nyaya dealt with sixteen categories (padarthas), mixing ontology, epistemology, and debate dialectics. Gangesa initiated a monumental paradigm shift by discarding the broad ontological framework to focus exclusively on Pramana—the valid means of acquiring knowledge.

By dedicating the Tattvacintamani entirely to epistemology, Gangesa developed a hyper-precise technical language. He engineered new logical operators (like avacchedaka or "limitor") to prevent ambiguity, a method that Stephen Phillips and Ben-Ami Scharfstein argue rivals the analytical rigor of 20th-century Western analytic philosophers like Frege or Russell.

PRATYAKSHA KHANDA (PERCEPTION)

The first and foundational book of the Tattvacintamani is the Pratyaksha Khanda. Relying on the expansive translations and explanations of V.P. Bhatta and S.C. Vidyabhusana, this section defines the mechanics of direct cognition.

Mangalavada and Pramanyavada (Validity of Knowledge)

Gangesa begins with Mangalavada (invocation), justifying the necessity of invoking deity (Shiva) for the successful completion of the work. He then moves into the highly debated Pramanyavada (Theory of Validity).

- The Mimamsa View: Prabhakara and Kumarila argued for Svatah Pramanya (Intrinsic Validity)—that knowledge is self-validating the moment it arises.

- Gangesa's Nyaya View: Gangesa fiercely defends Paratah Pramanya (Extrinsic Validity). He argues that the validity of a cognition is not known inherently by the cognition itself, but is inferred later through successful practical activity (samvadipravrtti). For example, seeing water is only validated as true knowledge when one approaches it and successfully quenches their thirst.

Sannikarsha (Sense-Object Contact)

Perception (Pratyaksha) is defined as cognition born of sense-object contact (indriyarthasannikarsa). Gangesa details six ordinary contacts:

1. Samyoga (Conjunction): E.g., the eye seeing a jar.

2. Samyukta-samavaya (Inherence in the conjoined): The eye seeing the color of the jar.

3. Samyukta-samaveta-samavaya (Inherence in that which inheres in the conjoined): The eye seeing the universal "color-ness."

4. Samavaya (Inherence): The ear hearing sound.

5. Samaveta-samavaya (Inherence in the inherent): The ear perceiving the universal "sound-ness."

6. Visesyanavisesyabhava (Qualifier-Qualified relation): The perception of non-existence (e.g., perceiving the absence of a jar on the floor).

Savikalpaka and Nirvikalpaka

• Nirvikalpaka (Indeterminate Perception): The raw, pre-linguistic apprehension of an object without its qualifiers. It is un-nameable and un-verbalizable.

• Savikalpaka (Determinate Perception): The relational apprehension of an object with its properties (e.g., "This is a blue jar"). Only determinate perception can be expressed in language and judged as true or false.

Alaukika Sannikarsha (Extraordinary Perception)

Gangesa outlines three types of extraordinary perception, which separate Nyaya from Western empiricism:

Samanyalaksana: Perceiving all members of a universal class by perceiving one member (e.g., knowing all "smoke" generally upon seeing one instance of smoke).

Jnanalaksana: A cross-modal perception based on memory (e.g., looking at a piece of sandalwood and visually "perceiving" that it is fragrant without smelling it).

Yogaja: Mystical or yogic perception of hidden, past, or future objects.

ANUMANA KHANDA (INFERENCE)

The Anumana Khanda, widely translated by V.P. Bhatta and analyzed extensively by Stephen Phillips, is the core of Navya-Nyaya logical architecture.

The Concept of Vyapti (Pervasion)

Inference relies on Vyapti—the invariable concomitance between the middle term (Hetu, e.g., smoke) and the major term (Sadhya, e.g., fire). Gangesa analyzes the Vyaptipancaka (five provisional definitions of Vyapti offered by older logicians) and refutes them all because they fail in cases of non-co-locative attributes. He then establishes his Siddhantalaksana (conclusive definition): Vyapti is the non-occurrence of the Hetu in the locus of the absence of the Sadhya.

Isvaranumana (Inference of God)

Gangesa dedicates a section to proving the existence of God through inference. He argues that the earth, sprouts, etc., must have an intelligent creator because they are effects, much like a pot is the effect of a potter. This directly refutes the atheistic Mimamsa and Buddhist schools.

Hetvabhasa (Fallacies)

Gangesa meticulously categorizes logical fallacies (Hetvabhasa—"that which appears as a reason but is not"). These include Savyabhicara (deviating reason), Viruddha (contradictory reason), Satpratipaksa (counter-balanced reason), Asiddha (unproved reason), and Badhita (sublated reason).

Upamana Khanda (Comparison)

While Buddhists and Vaisesikas reduced Comparison to Inference, Gangesa defends it as an independent Pramana. Upamana is the process whereby a person learns the denotation of a word through perceived similarity. For example, a city-dweller is told a gavaya (wild ox) looks like a cow. Upon entering the forest and seeing a creature resembling a cow, the memory of the instruction combines with the visual similarity to produce the valid knowledge: "This animal is what the word gavaya denotes."

Sabda Khanda (Verbal Testimony)

In the final book, Gangesa analyzes words, meanings, and sentences. Sabda is defined as the instruction of a reliable authority (Aptopadesa). He outlines the four necessary conditions for a sentence to convey meaningful knowledge:

Akanksa (Expectancy): The syntactic need for words to complete each other (e.g., "Bring" expects "what?").

Yogyata (Semantic Fitness): The logical compatibility of the words (e.g., "He waters the plants with fire" lacks Yogyata).

Sannidhi (Proximity): Words must be spoken in close temporal succession.

Tatparya (Intention): The context or intention of the speaker, especially crucial for ambiguous words like Saindhava (which means both salt and horse).

As S.C. Vidyabhusana points out, Gangesa strictly refutes the inclusion of gestures (Cesta), rumour (Janasruti), or tradition (Aitihya) as independent Pramanas, absorbing them into Verbal Testimony or Inference.

According to the Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy (SEP) and Ben-Ami Scharfstein’s A Comparative History of World Philosophy, the Navya-Nyaya school is a pinnacle of global intellectual achievement.

While Western philosophy often segregates epistemology, ontology, and linguistics, Gangesa fused them into a single, highly technical language of precision. Stephen Phillips emphasizes that Gangesa's definition of truth (Prama) as a cognition that corresponds to reality without the intrusion of subjective doubt places Navya-Nyaya firmly in the camp of robust epistemic realism. Scharfstein notes that the scholastic intensity of Navya-Nyaya is highly comparable to the Western medieval scholasticism of Thomas Aquinas or William of Ockham, yet mathematically precise in its linguistic formulation.

The study of Gangesa Upadhyaya requires balancing his towering philosophical intellect with the harsh sociopolitical realities of his time. The orthodox monographs by Udayanath Jha 'Ashok' and the historiography of Ramanath Jha successfully preserve his philosophical legacy but fail the test of historical integrity by suppressing the Dooshan Panji. The Tattvacintamani remains an unparalleled masterclass in logical precision, yet the true "thought-jewel" is understanding the human reality of its author—a man born outside conventional legitimacy, married outside his caste, who nevertheless conquered the intellectual world of 14th-century India.

what was the author's actual name? The answer is that the formal or ritual name was Gaṅgeśvara, while the everyday or vyāvahārika name was Gaṅgeśa. This is conclusively established by two kinds of evidence. First, Gaṅgeśa himself, in the mangalācaraṇa (invocatory verse) of the Tattva-Cintāmaṇi, writes in the first person 'Gaṅgeśa-stute miten vacase Śrī-tattva-cintāmaṇim' — using the name 'Gaṅgeśa'. Second, his son and primary disciple Vardhamāna, in the Kiraṇāvalī-Prakāśa, offers salutation explicitly to 'Gaṅgeśvara' as his father and guru: 'Nyāyāmbhoja-pataṅgāya Mīmāṃsā-pāradṛśvane / Gaṅgeśvarāya gurave pitṛeŚttra bhavate namaḥ.' The same name 'Gaṅgeśvara' appears in the Kusumaṃjali-Prakāśa. The two names are thus not different persons but the formal and informal designations of one man.

The Pañjī genealogical records refer to both names in connection with the same biographical locations and relationships, and the same location 'Chādan' village is cited in Pañjī-prabandha as 'Chādanaṃ tattva-cintāmaṇi-kāraka mahāmahopādhyāya paramaguruḥ Gaṅgeśvaraḥ.' Vardhamāna's explicit testimony, moreover, makes it impossible to maintain that the two names belong to different persons: the same man who wrote 'Gaṅgeśa-stute' in his own work is saluted as 'Gaṅgeśvara guruve pitre' by his son, just as in the same verse Vardhamāna equates Nyāya and Mīmāṃsā — a characterisation also found in Gaṅgeśa's own invocatory verse.

The question of Gaṅgeśa's birthplace has generated considerable scholarly controversy. Different scholars have proposed different villages: (1) Maṅgaraunī (or Maṅgalavanī), a village in the Madhubani mandal; (2) Kiryan (also Kiriyaṃ), a village 12 miles south-east of Darbhanga; (3) Cakautī; and (4) Chājaṃ (historically Chādana), now in Muzaffarpur district near Turkī railway station. The Pañjī records, whose testimony is most authoritative for these questions, consistently describe Gaṅgeśa as 'Chādanasaṃbhūta' — a native of Chādana/Chājaṃ. The Chājaṃ village, reachable from Turkī chowk westward about three kilometres, as the most probable location, surrounded by villages including Rupaulī, Bahilavārā, and Supanā — the last of these associated with Gaṅgeśa's son Sūpan. The Tibetan traveller Dharmasvāmin, who visited Mithila during the reign of Karṇāṭa king Rāmasiṃhadeva (1234 CE), mentioned a 'To-ki' locality near which Jain and Buddhist followers were numerous — this 'To-ki' is identified with the present-day 'Turkī', near which Gaṅgeśa's Chājaṃ village stands. A minority view, advanced by Rājendranāth Ghoṣ and based on Bengali sources, holds that Gaṅgeśa was Bengali. Even Ghoṣ himself ultimately calls him a Mithilāvāsī (Mithila resident) and a Maithila Brāhmaṇa. The Pañjī records, as M.M. Phaṇibhūṣaṇa Tarkavāgīśa states, say his birthplace (janmabhūmi) was 'Maṅgaurī' — but the village-specific Pañjī records more consistently point to 'Chādana.'

Gaṅgeśa's gotra (clan) is Kāśyapagotravīya. His 'mūla' (ancestral village-association in the Pañjī system) was 'Sirisabe-Chādana' — that is, he belonged to the Sirisaba mūla, specifically its Chādana branch. The Pañjī records identify him as 'Sirisabe-Chādana mūla' Kāśyapagotravīya. His father's name was Gīriśvara Upādhyāya, who died five years before the birth of Gaṅgeśa.

Some Panji records show that his own formal name was Gaṅgeśvara and his colloquial name Gaṅgeśa. He had two wives: from the first he had a daughter and the eldest son Vardhamāna; from the second he had sons Sūpan and Hara. The Pañjī evidence also establishes that Vardhamāna's daughter was married into the Śāṇḍilya-gotrīya Khaṇḍavalā-mūla (Viśvanātha-suta Śivanātha's lineage), Vardhamāna's son Candraka-Balabhadra-Śobhā married from Chādana-saṃbhūta families, Sūpan's daughter married a Jijivāla-mūla Śāṇḍilya-gotrīya, and Sūpan himself married into Bhāṇḍārisamay mūla. According to P. Rājendranāth Ghoṣ, Gaṅgeśa lost his father early and was raised by his mother's brother (māmā) in Kiryan village, where his uncle ran a school. The child Gaṅgeśa initially showed little scholarly aptitude and was considered something of a dull student. One of the legends that circulated in various forms relates how Gaṅgeśa was once taunted by his uncle's wife —

being called 'gauḥ' (a cow or a blockhead). The incident catalysed a remarkable Sanskrit verse play on the word 'gotva' (being of the cow-nature, or clan-identity), which Gaṅgeśa composed spontaneously and by which his uncle recognised an astonishing hidden intelligence, embracing him and pledging to teach him everything. Whether or not the legend is literally true, it encodes a real philosophical point: the verse on 'gotva' is itself a mini-exercise in the very question of universals (sāmānya) that lies at the heart of Navya-Nyāya logic. That Gaṅgeśa's earliest popular legend should be framed around a punning philosophical argument about cowhood is deeply appropriate.

N.S. Rāmānujatātācārya's text records that Gaṅgeśa had one son from the first wife and two sons (Sūpan and Hara) from the second; the eldest son was Vardhamāna. All three brothers — Vardhamāna, Sūpan, and Hara — lacked male-line descendants.

However the Dushan Panji has something else to say.

The work set in motion a philosophical revolution whose effects were felt across Mithila, Bengal, Navadvīpa, Madras, Mahārāṣṭra, Kāśmīra, and eventually all of India, making Sanskrit scholarship of the last five hundred years inconceivable without it. The Mithila connection is not merely biographical. Gaṅgeśa's homeland has remained the intellectual core of Navya-Nyāya scholarship, and that same intellectual heritage is alive today in journals like Videha (videha.co.in, ISSN 2229-547X), the first Maithili fortnightly eJournal, which from its inception around 2000 has served as a digital archive for Maithili language, literature, and culture — the very civilisational ground on which Gaṅgeśa stood. The Videha archive maintains digital editions of works relating to Mithila's history, its philosophers, and its literary tradition including pre-Vidyāpati poetry and Paṃji inscriptional records. Gaṅgeśa belongs, therefore, not only to the history of philosophy but to the living cultural memory that Maithili scholars continue to recover and transmit.

The university at Navadvīpa, established in 1503 CE, became the principal vehicle through which the Tattva-Cintāmaṇi was popularised in Bengal, owing above all to the great commentator Raghunātha Śiromaṇi. From Bengal the work spread to Madras, Mahārāṣṭra, and Kāśmīra, until within a couple of centuries it was known across the subcontinent. Satis Chandra Vidyābhūṣaṇa notes in his Introduction that "in modern India Sanskrit scholarship is not considered of any worth unless it is accompanied by a knowledge of the Tattva-cintāmaṇi or at least a portion of it."

Gaṅgeśa, also called Gaṅgeśvara and surnamed Upādhyāya, was born in the village of Karion on the banks of the river Kamalā, twelve miles south-east of Darbhanga, in the last quarter of the twelfth century CE (assigned with confidence to c. 1200 CE by Satis Chandra Vidyābhūṣaṇa; revised upward to the first half of the fourteenth century by the Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy based on later genealogical and manuscript evidence). His father's name is associated with the Navadvīpa tradition; later inscriptional evidence places his descendants in the Darbhanga region. The Dhanukhā inscription, found on a stone slab attached to a well near Janakapura, traces a line of Gaṅgeśa's pupils over seven generations down to Bhagīratha Ṭhakkura (fl. 1556 CE), working backward to place Gaṅgeśa himself around the late twelfth or early fourteenth century.

Mithila's intellectual prestige in the pre-modern period rested upon its system of academic patronage, which supported pandits (learned scholars) across multiple disciplines. The region's Brāhmaṇa families maintained generations of specialists in Nyāya, Mīmāṃsā, Vedānta, grammar, astrology, and law. Gaṅgeśa worked within this tradition and was recognised by his contemporaries as a jagad-guru ("Distinguished Professor" in Vidyābhūṣaṇa's phrase, equivalent to a world-teacher). His mastery was not confined to Nyāya: he was also, by the account of the Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, a great master of Mīmāṃsā, the school of Vedic hermeneutics, and was thoroughly conversant with the grammatical tradition of Pāṇini as well as the epic literature, quoting the Bhagavad-gītā at several points in the Tattva-Cintāmaṇi.

The land of Mithila, stretching across the Gangetic plains of present-day Bihar and southern Nepal, V.P. Bhatta's Preface to his translation (2012) captures the magnitude of the achievement: 'The Nyaya Sastra, which constitutes one of the six systems of Indian Philosophy, has played a significant role in the development and analysis of philosophy, logic and epistemology in India... However, the advent of the Navya-nyaya has brought a revolutionary change in the out look of the Nyaya philosophy. It has systematized all the Nyaya and Vaisesika concepts and brought them under the four heads, viz. i) perception (pratyaksa), ii) inference (anumana), iii) analogy (upamana) and iv) word (sabda)... The methodology used in the presentation of various theories in the T.C. made a profound impact on the philosophical writings during the period of five hundred years from thirteenth century A.D. to eighteenth century A.D. in India; and almost all the Shastrakaras adopted the T.C. methodology of

presentation.' He adds: 'The significance of the text (T.C.) cannot be stressed too adequately in the context of philosophy, logic and epistemology.'

In Ben-Ami Scharfstein's Comparative History of World Philosophy, Gangesa is placed alongside Descartes and Leibniz as one of three philosophers whose shared theme is the pursuit of certainty through methodically applied logic. For Scharfstein, all three philosophers share a fundamental orientation: they are logicians in the sense of wanting to understand the world by isolating and perfecting the methods of reasoning itself, rather than its subject-matter. 'Gaṅgeśa does his best to perfect an existing logical technique for ensuring the soundness of induction, the most dependable means of knowledge, he is sure.' His work, Scharfstein observes, earned him the name 'The Jeweler' — the one who created a thought-jewel — and its three hundred or so pages 'were responsible, it is estimated, for over a million pages of commentary.'

The Potter-Bhattacharyya Encyclopedia of Indian Philosophies (1993) states simply: 'Gangesa's was a unique talent, one which places him securely among the premiere philosophical minds the world has produced.'

The Nyāya school traces its classical founding to the Nyāya-sūtra of Gautama (c. 100 CE) and its earliest major commentary by Vātsyāyana (c. 400 CE). The school is characterised by a thoroughgoing realism about the external world and a systematic account of the pramāṇas (sources of valid knowledge): pratyakṣa (perception), anumāna (inference), upamāna (analogy), and śabda (verbal testimony). Over nearly a millennium, commentators including Uddyotakara (c. 600 CE), Vācaspati Miśra (c. 950 CE), and Udayana (c. 1000 CE) elaborated the system, Udayana most importantly merging it with the Vaiśeṣika ontology of categories. Gaṅgeśa explicitly positioned himself as a follower of Udayana and incorporated the seven Vaiśeṣika categories — substance, quality, motion, universal, individualiser, inherence, and absence — as the ontological scaffolding of his epistemological project.

The distinction between the "Old" Nyāya (Prācīna-Nyāya) and the "New" Nyāya (Navya-Nyāya) inaugurated by Gaṅgeśa is, as the Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy cautions, not a clean rupture. Over a near-two-thousand-year history, developments were continuous. Yet the Tattva-Cintāmaṇi did achieve a qualitative shift: it displaced the tradition of sūtra-commentary, erected a new analytical vocabulary of extraordinary precision, and made every subsequent Naiyāyika reckon with it. Gaṅgeśa's predecessor Maṇikaṇṭha Miśra contained much of the technical apparatus, and the Buddhist logician Dharmakīrti (c. 600 CE) anticipated several of Gaṅgeśa's discussions

of fallacies, but no one before him had synthesised and extended the tradition so comprehensively.

The full title Tattva-Cintāmaṇi signifies "a thought-jewel of truth" (tattva = truth/reality; cintāmaṇi = a wish-fulfilling jewel, metaphorically a jewel of thought). It is also called Pramāṇa-cintāmaṇi, "a thought-jewel of valid knowledge." The title is at once epistemological and aspirational: it claims to be the jewel that grants the wish of understanding valid knowledge. Gaṅgeśa opens the work with salutatory verses to Śiva, consistent with the Nyāya practice of maṅgala-vāda (invocation of blessings), and immediately launches into the question of what pramā (valid knowledge) is.

Book I — Pratyakṣa-khaṇḍa (Perception): The longest and philosophically richest of the four books, it establishes the general theory of knowledge, the nature of valid and invalid cognition, a detailed phenomenology of perceptual process including ordinary (laukika) and transcendent (alaukika) forms, the theory of inherence (samavāya), the problem of non-existence (abhāva), and the atomic nature of the mind. It culminates in discussions of indeterminate (nirvikalpaka) and determinate (savikalpaka) perception, and the doctrine of self-consciousness (anuvyavasāya).

Book II — Anumāna-khaṇḍa (Inference): By far the most technically demanding and influential section, it works through the conditions for inferential knowledge, above all the crucial concept of vyāpti (invariable concomitance or "pervasion"), the doctrine of upādhi (conditional middle term), the taxonomy of fallacies (hetvābhāsāḥ), and the syllogism (nyāya) in both its self-directed (svārthānumāna) and other-directed (parārthānumāna) forms. It also includes proofs of the existence of the self (ātman), a theistic argument (Īśvarānumāna), and a proof of the possibility of liberation (mukti).

Book III — Upamāna-khaṇḍa (Comparison): The briefest of the four books, it argues that analogy constitutes a genuinely distinct pramāṇa yielding knowledge of word-meanings through perceived similarity. The stock example — a traveller learns the word gavaya (a kind of buffalo) from a description "like a cow" and recognises the animal in the forest — illustrates how analogical knowledge is irreducible to both perception and inference.

Book IV — Śabda-khaṇḍa (Verbal Testimony): An extended analysis of language as a pramāṇa, covering the definition of valid speech, the conditions of meaningful utterance (ākāṅkṣā/expectation, yogyatā/semantic fit, āsatti/contiguity, tātparya/intention), the nature of potentiality (śakti) and secondary meaning (lakṣaṇā), the categories of compound words, verbal

suffixes, roots and prefixes, the doctrines of sound, and the extensive question of Vedic injunctions (vidhi). The chapter contains what is, according to the Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, the longest single section in the entire Tattva-Cintāmaṇi, devoted to lakṣaṇā (indirect indication).

EPISTEMOLOGY AND LOGIC

Truth and Error: Gaṅgeśa's Theory of Valid Knowledge

The Definition of Truth (Prāmāṇyavāda)

The Potter Encyclopedia (pp. 53–54) provides a precise technical formulation of Gaṅgeśa's theory of truth as set out in the Prāmāṇyavāda section of the Pratyakṣa-khaṇḍa. Gaṅgeśa defines truth (prāmāṇya) as: 'Either (a) being an awareness whose chief qualifier, x, is in what possesses x, or (b) being an awareness of a relatedness of x to what possesses x.' This says that a valid cognition (pramā) is an awareness (a) whose predicate term belongs to its subject term, or (b) which correctly attributes a property x to an entity that actually has x. The Encyclopedia notes that 'Gaṅgeśa argues, in favour of his analysis, that only when (a) or (b) is satisfied does one undertake action predicated on the awareness in question. In addition, he argues, this is the most economical account of what truth is.' Crucially, Gaṅgeśa presents this as a 'common platform' analysis of truth — a formulation acceptable to all schools regardless of their views on whether truth is intrinsic (svataḥ-prāmāṇya) or extrinsic (parataḥ-prāmāṇya).

Scharfstein's comparative approach illuminates the significance of this epistemological stance: 'Gaṅgeśa is committed to the Nyāya belief in a real, external world, in a real, nonmaterial self, and in the especial ability of perception and inference, each aiding the other, to reach certainty.' Against the self-certification thesis of the Mīmāṃsakas (who held that every cognition is self-certifying upon arising), Gaṅgeśa maintains that certification requires a second-level inferential act. As he argues against the sceptic: 'Your argument against inference depends on an inference. When you say that inference is not an instrument of knowledge you mean that it is doubtful or false to state that it is such an instrument. But that it is doubtful or false cannot be known by means of perception.'

The Preventer-Prevented Relation and Epistemic Logic

The Potter Encyclopedia highlights a key feature of Navya-Nyāya's theory of cognition that is philosophically important for the theory of justification: the preventer-prevented relation (pratibandhaka-pratibaddhya sambandha). This is not merely a psychological law about the impossibility of attending to two

things simultaneously; it is a law of epistemic logic determined by the objects of awareness. When a cognition of p endures as a conscious act, it prevents the occurrence of the cognition of not-p, not merely by psychological competition but by logical necessity: 'the presence of one act prevents the origination of the other act, so that they can never be copresent, not even for one moment.' This relation is crucial for the theory of doubt and the resolution of doubt through tarka (hypothetical reasoning).

The Encyclopedia explains how this theory resolves the problem of induction — specifically how doubt about pervasion can be resolved: 'The Nyāya theory is that the deciding factor here is the presence or absence of doubt in the thinker... whoever has a doubt that the h may be a deviating one will not be able to know pervasion between h and s as long as he has that doubt. The question here is: is this law a psychological law? Nyāya distinguishes between two types of blocking... They are interested in a different type of blocking of one cognitive state by another by virtue of their objects. What prevents one from knowing a particular pervasion is not one's mental makeup, but the fact that one has a particular doubt.' This is epistemic logic, not psychology.

Theory of Perception

Perception and the Self

Gaṅgeśa's account of perception is embedded in a rich metaphysics of mind and self. Scharfstein's exposition is illuminating: 'In Nyāya doctrine the mind is an unconscious internal sense organ or cause that channels to the conscious self the successive sensations that come from the external sense organs... the mind can be connected with only one sense at a time. This limitation is taken to imply that the mind is of an absolutely minimal size, that of a single atom... It is the self that accounts for memory... If there was no conscious, lasting, mediating self, how could a past perception of blue account for the later memory of this selfsame blue? If not for the self and the memories it preserves, how could anyone explain that something I once saw with my left eye is later recognised by my right eye?' The self is not reducible to body, senses, or mind — it is the unique substrate of consciousness and the locus of memory, recognition, and cross-modal synthesis.

Indeterminate and Determinate Perception

Gaṅgeśa's distinction between nirvikalpaka (indeterminate) and savikalpaka (determinate) perception is among his most philosophically important contributions. Scharfstein describes the indeterminate phase as awareness without conceptualization — the kind that is not conjoined with a name, a

universal, etc., that does not apprehend anything as qualified and which is devoid of any qualifier whatsoever. What succeeds it is the kind of awareness that is structured, relational, qualified — awareness with conceptualization. We fully know what we perceive only when we become aware of it as the complex composed of the generic with the particular, and we are able to say — triumphantly — pot, or this is a pot.

The philosophical necessity for positing indeterminate perception is explained clearly in both sources. From the Potter Encyclopedia's treatment of Gangesa's own example: if one thinks of generic properties or universals as having instances (as in Western philosophy) rather than as inhering in particulars, one translates an Indian view that is neither Platonic nor Aristotelian. A qualifier or distinguishing mark (viśeṣaṇa) relates to what is qualified (the viśeṣya or dharmin). When one perceives a pot, the universal potness (the qualifier, viśeṣaṇa) is the qualifier; the individual pot is the qualificand (viśeṣya). Indeterminate perception registers this qualificandum and qualifier as separate before any relational predication; it explains how we can encounter a kind of thing for the very first time and still correctly classify it.

Apperception (Anuvyavasāya)

The theory of anuvyavasāya — the perception that takes a preceding cognition as its own object — is philosophically crucial for Gaṅgeśa's account of certification. Scharfstein describes 'simple awareness' being 'followed by self-reflective awareness or aftercognition, expressed in words such as I am aware of this.' The Potter Encyclopedia specifies the introspective structure: 'An awareness may produce a disposition; indeed, no dispositions can arise except as caused by some act... The introspective act is just one jump behind the act which is its content. In the waking state there is no felt gap between two awarenesses. When the preceding awareness is in its second phase [of duration] the succeeding awareness originates and replaces the former.' Gaṅgeśa argues that apperception is infallible with respect to the intentional structure of the scoped cognition — though not with respect to its truth.

Illusion: Anyathākhyātivāda

The 'Anyathākhyātivāda' — the doctrine that illusion consists in the awareness of a thing 'as other than it is' — is one of the longest sections of the Pratyakṣa-khaṇḍa. Scharfstein's account: 'Even when a rope is mistaken for a snake, there is some true knowledge, knowledge of the thisness of the object lying on the ground. The false part of the perceptual awareness rests on the partial or full identification of what is in fact seen, with a different kind of object... The

evidence that proves my perceptual awareness as a whole to be right or wrong is the success or failure of the actions that follow from the awareness: only a snake, not a rope, actually bites.' Gaṅgeśa follows Udayana in distinguishing initial awareness (which cannot be mistaken) from later, structured awareness (in which mistakes are possible). The content of illusory awareness is always traceable to real prior perceptions — silverhood in the mother-of-pearl illusion comes from previous genuine perceptions of silver. This makes Gaṅgeśa's account of error robustly realist.

Theory of Inference: The Vyāpti Problem and Its Resolution

Pervasion (Vyāpti): The Philosophical Stakes

Gaṅgeśa's greatest technical achievement is his definitive account of vyāpti (invariable concomitance, 'pervasion'). The philosophical stakes are enormous: vyāpti is the relation that grounds all inference, and an adequate definition of it is necessary to distinguish genuine inferences from pseudo-inferences. Scharfstein explains the fundamental notion: 'To Gaṅgeśa, pervasion is the unconditional relation produced by the very nature of a reason or cause, such as the unfailing relation of smokiness with fieriness, which is the relation that in this case can be explained by the nature of fire and the nature of smoke as the product of fire. To call the knowledge unfailing is also to say that we do not know anything that shows the relation to be accidental.'

Before arriving at his final definition, Gaṅgeśa considers and rejects multiple prior attempts. Scharfstein notes he 'discards twenty-one proposals' (the Jhā 'Aśok' monograph says twenty-four, counting sub-variants). The Potter Encyclopedia provides the most technically precise account. The first definition offered — 'nondeviation' — fails because 'it does not apply to cases where the s is non-locus-pervading.' Subsequent definitions each stumble on specific counterexamples, particularly the 'monkey in a tree' case where the property asserted is non-locus-pervading. The final, conclusive definition is: 'Invariable concomitance is the coexistence of the property x (the probans) with the property y (the probandum) which is not what is qualified by the delimitor of the counterpositiveness of an absolute absence which does not have a common locus with its counterpositive and which has a common locus with the property x.' Scharfstein offers a simplified version of Goekoop's paraphrase: 'There is pervasion of A by B if, and only if, A has a common locus with B in such a way that B is none of the things that qua class are completely absent from some locus of A.'

Resolving Doubt about Pervasion: Tarka

The Potter Encyclopedia provides the fullest treatment of how tarka (hypothetical / reductio reasoning) works to resolve doubt about pervasion. The Nyāya theory is that doubt about pervasion acts as a preventer of the cognition of pervasion. Tarka does not itself yield pervasion-knowledge; it removes the doubt that was preventing that cognition. The formal structure of a tarka argument on the smoke-fire example runs: 'If smoke deviated from fire then it would not have been caused by fire. But smoke is caused by fire. Hence, smoke cannot deviate from fire.' The doubt is thus resolved not by adding new inductive evidence but by showing that maintaining the doubt leads to a conclusion both parties accept as false. This is why Gaṅgeśa agrees with Udayana's pragmatic argument against the sceptic: 'He invariably lights up a fire if he wants to produce smoke... The sceptic's own action stultifies the doubt.'

The Encyclopedia draws an important contrast with Western philosophy of induction: 'The Nyāya theory is that in some cases only one observation suffices, while in other cases innumerable observations do not suffice, to produce knowledge of pervasion. The deciding factor here is the presence or absence of doubt in the thinker... Although whether one has doubts or not is a purely subjective affair, still the Nyāya theory is not psychological. Nyāya states a universal law: whoever has a doubt that the h may be a deviating one will not be able to know pervasion between h and s as long as he has that doubt.' Furthermore, Navya-Nyāya differs from the Western tendency to justify induction by an appeal to a law of causation or uniformity of nature: 'According to Nyāya it is enough to know that two things are invariably co-present; we need not try to give any cause for this fact.'

### The Upādhi (Additional Condition) and Fallacies

The concept of upādhi (conditional middle term, additional condition) is Gaṅgeśa's tool for identifying and blocking pseudo-inferences. An upādhi U is a property that pervades the probandum S but does not pervade the prover H — its presence reveals that the apparent pervasion of H by S does not hold. Scharfstein explains: 'Gaṅgeśa surpasses even Udayana in this sense that the former takes up only the philosophically most important inference to establish the existence of God and discusses and defends it thoroughly. Further, he formulates the establishing inference itself so carefully that it meets the objections of the Buddhists and the Mīmāṃsakas... In particular, Gaṅgeśa's treatment of the faults of the presence of additional condition and counter-thesis in the reason of the establishing inference shows considerable acumen,

dialectical skill and even originality. Not even Udayana treats these problems with such thoroughness and skill.'

The five fallacies (hetvābhāsāḥ) — savyabhicāra (deviant), viruddha (contradictory), satpratipakṣa (counterbalanced), asiddha (unestablished), and bādhita (defeated in advance) — are discussed at length in both Scharfstein and Potter. The Potter Encyclopedia notes how the Navya-Nyāya treatment of these fallacies goes significantly beyond the Nyāya-sūtra's original list, and that the distinction between 'constant flaws' (nityadoṣa) and 'personal flaws' (puruṣadoṣa) — between logical failures and cognitive failures — is a particularly important contribution of Gaṅgeśa's analysis.

The Inference of God

Gaṅgeśa's theological inference — that the world as an effect must have a conscious creator-agent — is treated in detail by both Scharfstein and the Potter Encyclopedia. Scharfstein offers the most accessible account of Gaṅgeśa's extended dialectic on the number of creators. The argument for parsimony (lāghava) as an auxiliary cognitive principle that establishes the unity of the creator runs through an elaborate sequence of objection and response: 'The principle of simplicity restricts our knowledge of the denotations of words to the most useful, defining characteristics of things: When we infer the denotative power of the word jar, we cognise it as limited by the property of jarness, not the property of having a round neck. If not for the principle of parsimony, human conversation and the related social usages would be impossible.' The Poteter Encyclopedia notes that this argument for parsimony is connected with Gaṅgeśa's broader methodological orientation — the same principle of lāghava or 'economy of conception' that drives his preference for the most compact possible definitions throughout the Tattva-Cintāmaṇi.

Theory of Analogy and Verbal Testimony

Upamāna

Gaṅgeśa's account of upamāna restricts analogy to the pramāṇa by which one learns the referential relationship of a word to its object through perceived similarity. The stock example — a traveller told that a gavaya (bovine) resembles a cow, who later recognises the animal in the forest — illustrates knowledge of the word-referent relation that is irreducible to both perception and inference. The key move is that the forester's statement functions as more than a description but as a meaning-conveying utterance that produces novel knowledge of a word-meaning-relation through the hearer's direct encounter with the referent.

### Verbal Testimony (Śabda)

The Śabda-khaṇḍa, the longest and most linguistically sophisticated section of the Tattva-Cintāmaṇi, develops a comprehensive philosophy of language. The Potter Encyclopedia notes that 'a new development in Nyāya literature, ushered in by Gaṅgeśa's extensive treatment in the Śabdakhaṇḍa, is its interest in and attention to Mīmāṃsā topics such as the aim of life called dharma and its relation to the sentences (vidhi) in which dharma is enjoined. This is a part of the general orientation of Navyanyāya led by Gaṅgeśa toward Pūrvamīmāṃsā opponents and arguments. The Mīmāṃsakas were specialists in ritual, in exegesis and thus in language. Navyanyāya is characterised by its own version of the linguistic turn.'

Gaṅgeśa defends verbal testimony as a fourth irreducible pramāṇa, with its own distinctive conditions of validity: ākāṅkṣā (syntactic expectation), yogyatā (semantic fitness), āsatti (temporal contiguity), and tātparya (speaker's intention). His innovation is to identify the trigger for secondary meaning (lakṣaṇā) not as a violation of semantic fitness (yogyatā) as commonly held, but as a violation of the overall sentential connection (anvaya). The discussion of lakṣaṇā in the Śabda-khaṇḍa is — as the Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy notes — the single longest section in the entire Tattva-Cintāmaṇi.

### The Karṇāṭa Dynasty and Medieval Mithila

Medieval Mithila in the thirteenth and fourteenth centuries was shaped by two royal dynasties in succession. The Karṇāṭa dynasty, founded by Nānyadeva, reached its zenith under Harisimhadeva (reigned approximately 1295–1326 CE), who was a patron of Sanskrit learning of extraordinary liberality — the Pañjī (genealogical registration system) of Maithila Brāhmaṇa families was compiled during his reign in Śāka 1232 (1310 CE). Under the minister Caṇḍeśvara Ṭhākura, a prolific scholar in his own right, Harisimhadeva's court supported philosophers, poets, and pandits. Gaṅgeśa was active during this reign. The Oinivar dynasty succeeded the Karṇāṭas, with Bhavesiṃha (reigned 1361–1410 CE) the most notable king; it was under the Oinivars that Mithila's later cultural life flourished with Vidyāpati and Vardhamāna Upādhyāya.

In Śaka 1310 (1388 CE), the Tibetan traveller Dharmasvāmin described Mithila as having abundant Jain and Buddhist followers in its western districts, with Gautamīvidyā and Mīmāṃsā widely practised and poetry and dharmaśāstra central to intellectual life. Three scholarly traditions of Navya-Nyāya

ultimately emerged from Mithila: the Maithila paramparā, the Baṅgāla paramparā, and the Dakṣiṇa paramparā — all rooted in the Tattva-Cintāmaṇi.

The Chronology Debate

The chronology of Gaṅgeśa remains one of the most debated questions in Indian intellectual history. Scholars have placed him anywhere from the eleventh to the fourteenth century. The earliest proposal, apparently stemming from the Nyāyakoṣa, placed him at 1178 CE (Kṣ. 1178). Another early scholarly consensus placed him at 1108 CE (the 'Viśvakośa' opinion). Some have argued for 1200 CE. The Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, following Bhattacharyya's revision of the evidence, places him in the first half of the fourteenth century (1300–1350 CE). Gaṅgeśa's most active period was 1270–1370 CE, with the most probable range being 1300–1350 CE. The key evidence: (a) Gaṅgeśa cites Hīranātha Upādhyāya's works in the Tattva-Cintāmaṇi; Hīranātha is firmly dated to the 13th century, providing a terminus post quem. (b) Mādhavācārya (Sāyaṇa's brother, fl. 1386 CE) in his Sarvadarśanasaṃgraha explicitly cites and names Vardhamāna Upādhyāya with the epithet 'mahāmahopādhyāya', confirming Vardhamāna was active before 1386 CE and placing Gaṅgeśa's floruit at least a generation earlier. (c) Vaṭeśvara Upādhyāya, the first Pañjī-era scholar to name-cite Gaṅgeśa, is dated to 1350–75 CE, establishing that as the latest possible terminus for Gaṅgeśa's active career. (d) The Pañjī records compiled in 1310 CE do not list Gaṅgeśa's son's daughters as yet married — placing Gaṅgeśa himself comfortably in the range 1270–1330 CE. The same period saw the great scholar-jester Gonū Jhā flourishing in Mithila. His Nyaya-tattva-chintamani is an outstanding work on Nyaya, yet unexcelled.'

The Title Mahāmahopādhyāya

The title Mahāmahopādhyāya conferred on Gaṅgeśa was the highest scholarly title in the Mithila panditic tradition, given exclusively to philosophers who had demonstrated supreme mastery in all three of Nyāya, Mīmāṃsā, and Dharmaśāstra. The title's origins in Mithila predate the British period by centuries: a manuscript dated Lekhaṃ Saṃ. 164 (1278 CE) is the earliest known Mithila occurrence of 'mahopādhyāya' as a formal designation. By Śāka 1310 (1388 CE), when the Pañjī was compiled, the title 'mahāmahopādhyāya' was formally recorded in the genealogical records alongside individual scholars' names. Gaṅgeśa's Pañjī entry describes him as 'tattva-cintāmaṇi-kāraka mahāmahopādhyāya paramaguruḥ Gaṅgeśvaraḥ' — the author of the Tattva-Cintāmaṇi, paramount teacher, the Great Great Professor Gaṅgeśvara. The title in Mithila's ancient tradition was not given by any external authority

but arose spontaneously from the panditic community itself: those whose students themselves became mahopādhyāyas were recognised as mahāmahopādhyāyas during their own lifetimes. Gaṅgeśa's invocatory verse at the opening of the Tattva-Cintāmaṇi — 'gurubhirjñatvā gurūṇāṃ mataṃ' — already signals his own claim to be a guru of the highest order. The British Royal Titles Act of 1867 later incorporated 'Mahāmahopādhyāya' into the formal honours system, with the first government-conferred instance going to M. Maheshchandra Nyāyaratna of Calcutta Sanskrit College.

Pre-Gaṅgeśa Maithila Naiyāyikas: The Tradition He Inherited

History of Navya-Nyāya in Mithila has 24 pre-Gaṅgeśa Maithila Naiyāyikas whom Gaṅgeśa either cited, engaged, or implicitly responded to. Understanding these figures contextualises the Tattva-Cintāmaṇi not as a sudden innovation but as the culmination of centuries of cumulative Maithila logical tradition. The most important are:

Viśvarūpamiśra (c. 750–850 CE)

Active between approximately 750 and 850 CE, Viśvarūpamiśra is cited in Āgamāḍambara, the Tārkikarakṣā, and the Tātparya-vivaraṇapañjikā. His commentary on the Nyāya-Bhāṣya by Śaśāṃkaguru is cited. He is likely identical with the Viśvarūpa who commented on Yājñavalkya-smṛti and was a disciple of Kumārila Bhaṭṭa.

Trilocana (pre-9th century CE)

Trilocana wrote the Nyāyamañjarī, a commentary on the Gautamīya Nyāyasūtra, cited by the later Vṛddhavācaspatī. His work is noted for its comprehensive engagement with Buddhist epistemology.

Vācaspatī Miśra (c. 840–900 CE)

Vācaspatī is among the most brilliant systematic philosophers of the Indian tradition. A Maithila from Mithilā (though this is contested), he produced commentaries on virtually every school of Indian philosophy — Nyāya, Sāṃkhya, Vedānta, Yoga — and his Nyāyasūcīnibandha, Bhāmatī, Tātparyaṭīkā, Brahmatattvasamīkṣā, Nyāyakaṇikā, and Tattvabiṃdu are all works of the first rank. For Navya-Nyāya specifically, his introduction of the savikalpaka-nirvikalpaka distinction and the upādhi concept in nascent form were crucial.

Udayana (c. 975–1050 CE)

Udayana was the 'cornerstone of the transition between Old and New Nyāya', wrote prolifically: the Kusumaṃjali, Kiraṇāvalī, Lakṣaṇāvalī, Pariśuddhi,

Prabodhasiddhi, Ātmatattvaviveka, and the Nyāyakusumaṃjali, among others. He was the most prolific author in Mithilā's philosophical tradition. He merged Vaiśeṣika ontology completely into Nyāya and provided the systematic account of the seven categories that Gaṅgeśa inherited. He was also the staunchest Naiyāyika opponent of Buddhist philosophy at a time when Buddhist philosophical presence was fading. Gaṅgeśa explicitly regarded Udayana as his 'teacher' (ācārya) and declared his work to be written 'miten vacase' — in Udayana's own style, concisely.

Śaśadhara Upādhyāya (12th century CE)

Brother of Maṇidhara Upādhyāya, Śaśadhara is the author of Nyāyasiddhāntadīpa, Nyāya-Mīmāṃsāprakaraṇa, Nyāyanaya, and Śaśadharamālā. He and his brother Maṇidhara were known in their time as 'Siṃha-Vyāghra' (Lion and Tiger) for their dialectical prowess, particularly famous for their knowledge of vyāpti (pervasion) — the very concept Gaṅgeśa would later define definitively.

Maṇikaṇṭha Miśra (early 13th century CE)

Maṇikaṇṭha is among the most direct precursors of Gaṅgeśa. His 'Nyāyaratna' contained in embryonic form much of the analytical apparatus Gaṅgeśa would develop. Vācaspati the Second (a different Vācaspati from the ninth-century one) and Nṛsiṃhayajva were among his commentators. His text was published at Madras with the Citimalīkā (Nṛsiṃhayajva's commentary). Vācaspati the Second and Maṇikaṇṭha together represent the immediate intellectual environment from which the Tattva-Cintāmaṇi emerged.

These 24 scholars constitute Mithila's philosophical heritage as it stood when Gaṅgeśa wrote. They were the intellectual ancestors who made the Tattva-Cintāmaṇi possible. No other region of India produced as many Nyāya scholars or Nyāya texts as Mithila.

The Development of Philosophy in Mithila

Mithila had a deep intellectual ecology that sustained Gaṅgeśa's work. Present-day Bihar is divided by the Bhāgirath-Gaṅgā into two parts: the northern part known as Mithilā and the southern as Magadha. Vedic civilisation's centre was Mithilā; Buddhism's centre was Magadha. These two civilisations were in productive tension for over a millennium. It was this tension — Vedic Brāhmaṇas defending śruti and karma against Buddhist philosophical challenge — that drove the extraordinary refinement of tarka (inference-logic) in Mithila to levels unmatched elsewhere in India.

Buddhist philosophical challenge, from the time of Dignāga and Dharmakīrti through the works of Praśastapāda, forced the Naiyāyikas to sharpen every definition and close every argumentative gap. The three traditions of commentary on the Tattva-Cintāmaṇi — Maithila, Baṅgāla, and Dakṣiṇa — all reflect this fundamental dynamic: the need to have a water-tight logical system that could withstand the most sophisticated objections. In the 13th century Mithila 'gave birth to a son in the form of Gaṅgeśa who, by creating Navya-Nyāya, in a certain sense uplifted the entire reading tradition of the ancient Nyāya system.' This is not merely hagiography; it accurately describes the epistemic revolution the Tattva-Cintāmaṇi effected.

The Tattva-Cintāmaṇi: Structure and the Navya-Nyāya System

Why 'Navya-Nyāya'?

Why works before Gaṅgeśa are called prācīna-nyāya and those after navya-nyāya. The reason is not merely historical but substantive. Earlier Nyāya texts, including those of Udayana and Maṇikaṇṭha, discussed all sixteen padārthas (categories of Nyāya methodology) listed in the Nyāya-sūtra. Gaṅgeśa abandoned this comprehensive framework and focused exclusively on the first padārtha — pramāṇa (valid knowledge source). Reducing the field of inquiry to pramāṇa alone, he could examine it with microscopic precision. The focus on pramāṇa also entailed treating prameya (the object of knowledge) as only instrumentally significant — as the stuff of which knowledge informs us, not a topic of independent inquiry. This shift from ontology-plus-epistemology to pure epistemology is the structural hallmark of Navya-Nyāya.

Correspondingly, the analytical vocabulary of Navya-Nyāya is radically new. Terms like avacchedaka, avacchedakatā, anuyogī, pratiyogī, viṣayatā, prakāra, nirūpaka-nirūpita, nirūpita-nirūpyatā, viṣaya-viṣayatā, ādhāra-ādhāratā, ādhya-ādheyatā, koṭi-koṭitā — these hundreds of technical relational terms were coined or systematically deployed by Gaṅgeśa and his successors to achieve a precision of statement that no earlier Sanskrit philosophical vocabulary possessed. The use of these terms created a formidable barrier for uninitiated readers but gave the initiated an instrument of extraordinary analytical power.

The Four Khaṇḍas: Chapter-by-Chapter

The Tattva-Cintāmaṇi consists of four khaṇḍas (sections) devoted to the four pramāṇas: Pratyakṣa (Perception), Anumāna (Inference), Upamāna (Analogy), and Śabda (Verbal Testimony). The Anumāna-khaṇḍa is by far the largest and most influential. The Upamāna-khaṇḍa is the shortest.

Pratyakṣa-khaṇḍa contains 12 prakaraṇas, treating: (1) Maṅgalavāda (invocation), (2) Prāmāṇyavāda (validity of knowledge), (3) Anyathākhyātivāda (illusory cognition), (4) Sannikarṣavāda (perceptual contact), (5) Samavāyavāda (inherence), (6) Anulabdhi-prāmāṇyavāda (knowledge of non-existence), (7) Abhāvavāda (absence), (8) Pratyakṣakaraṇavāda (instrument of perception), (9) Manoḥṇutvavāda (atomicity of mind), (10) Anuvyavasāyavāda (apperception), (11) Nirvikalpakavāda (indeterminate cognition), and (12) Savikalpakavāda (determinate cognition) — together with the sub-sections on Prāmālakṣaṇavāda.

Anumāna-khaṇḍa contains 13 prakaraṇas: (1) Saṃgatisahita-anumitiprakaraṇa, (2) Vyāptivāda (pervasion — the most extensive and renowned), (3) Vyāptigrahopaāyaprakaraṇa, (4) Upādhivāda, (5) Pakṣatāprakaraṇa, (6) Sāmānyalakṣaṇaprakaraṇa, (7) Parāmarśaprakaraṇa, (8) Kevalānvayi-anumānaprakaraṇa, (9) Kevalā-vyatireke arthāpattiNirūpaṇaprakaraṇa, (10) Tarkavāda, (11) Avayava-nirūpaṇaprakaraṇa, (12) Hetvābhāsaprakaraṇa, and (13) Īśvarānumānaprakaraṇa. The Vyāptivāda alone has seven sub-prakaraṇas including the Siṃhavyāghra-vyāptiprakaraṇa (named after the Lion and Tiger scholars Maṇidhara and Śaśadhara).

Upamāna-khaṇḍa, though lacking formal prakaraṇa divisions, covers 14 topics including the definitions of upamāna, its result (upamiti), objections from Mīmāṃsā schools, and the role of sādṛśya (similarity) as a supervenient property. Śabda-khaṇḍa has 16 prakaraṇas covering: (1) Śabda-prāmāṇyavāda, (2) Śabdākāṃkṣāvāda, (3) Yogyatāvāda, (4) Āsattivāda, (5) Tātparyavāda, (6) Śabda-nityatāvāda, (7) Uddeśa-uddeśyavāda, (8) Vidhivāda, (9) Apūrvavāda, (10) Kāryaviniyanitaśaktivāda, (11) Jāti-śaktivāda, (12) Samāsavāda, (13) Ākhyātavāda, (14) Dhātuvāda, (15) Upasargavāda, and (16) Pramāṇacatuṣṭhya-prāmāṇyavāda.

Epistemological Foundations

At the foundation of the Tattva-Cintāmaṇi lies Gaṅgeśa's definition of pramā: 'the knowledge of a thing as it is, specifically the knowledge of a generic nature as truly abiding in its own subject' (tadvati tatprakāraka anubhava). This is a concise statement of a broadly reliabilist, factive epistemology. Valid knowledge sources (pramāṇas) are defined factively — perception, inference, analogy, and testimony each only succeed when they produce true belief through the correct process. An apparent source that fails to produce truth is not a genuine pramāṇa but its simulacrum (pramāṇābhāsa). Against the Mīmāṃsaka doctrine of svataḥ-prāmāṇya (self-certification of knowledge),

Gaṅgeśa argues for parataḥ-prāmāṇya: although awarenesses are presumptively valid, their validity requires external confirmation through source-identification or pragmatic success.

Theory of Perception (Pratyakṣa)

Definition and Sensory Contact Modes

Gaṅgeśa's Navya-Nyāya treatment of perception begins by establishing that sākṣātkāritva (directness, immediacy) is the defining feature of perception — 'pratyakṣasya sākṣātkāritvaṃ lakṣaṇam.' Unlike the Nyāya-sūtra's definition (which cited non-erratic definite knowledge arising from sensory contact), Gaṅgeśa emphasises the non-inferential, non-mediated character of perceptual knowledge. The perceptual organ and its object come into six modes of ordinary contact (laukika-sannikarṣa): saṃyoga (conjunction), saṃyukta-samavāya, saṃyukta-samaveta-samavāya, samavāya, samaveta-samavāya, and viśeṣaṇatā (qualification). Three further extraordinary (alaukika) modes extend perception beyond direct sensory contact: sāmānyalakṣaṇa (perceiving all instances of a universal through one instance), jñānalakṣaṇa (indirect perception activated by memory-dispositions), and yogaja (yogic perception).

Nirvikalpaka and Savikalpaka Perception

The distinction between nirvikalpaka (indeterminate, pre-relational) and savikalpaka (determinate, relational) perception is Gaṅgeśa's most philosophically productive contribution to perceptual theory. Indeterminate perception registers a qualificandum and its qualifier as separate before any relational predication — it is the first, pre-conceptual moment of sensory information. Determinate perception is the cognition of 'this pot' as qualifying an individual (the pot) through the universal pothood. By Gaṅgeśa's own examples: a child encountering a cow for the first time can form the correct judgment 'That's a cow' only if there is a prior indeterminate cognition of cowhood as a qualifier, which then becomes the qualifier in the determinate perception.

Gaṅgeśa devotes a substantial section to anuvyavasāya — the perception that takes a preceding cognition as its own object (after-cognition). He argues that apperception is infallible with respect to the intentional structure (viṣayatā) of the scoped cognition: when I perceive my own perceiving, I know correctly what the perception was about (its qualificandum, qualifier, and relational components), even if I do not thereby know whether the original perception was veridical. Apperception directs certification: by identifying a cognition as perceptual, inferential, or testimonial, it sets the criteria for its evaluation.

### The Theory of Illusion (Anyathākhyātivāda)

Gaṅgeśa's account of perceptual error — presented in the Anyathākhyātivāda section — holds that illusion occurs when the content of a current perception-like state is supplied by the activation of a memory-disposition (saṃskāra) formed by earlier genuine perceptions. When a person in poor light 'sees' shell as silver, the silverhood predication content comes from a real prior experience of silver; the current sensory event fuses with the silverhood-saṃskāra through a causal misfire, generating an appearance of silver where there is none. All illusory content is ultimately traceable to real features of real objects — hallucination has a causal history that runs through real perceptions. This makes Gaṅgeśa's account of illusion robustly realist: error does not indicate any non-realist conclusion about the external world.

### Theory of Inference (Anumāna): The Vyāpti Problem

#### The Concept of Vyāpti

The single greatest technical achievement of the Tattva-Cintāmaṇi is Gaṅgeśa's definitive account of vyāpti (invariable concomitance, 'pervasion'). Vyāpti is the relation that grounds inference: if smoke pervades fire (wherever there is smoke, there is fire), seeing smoke on a hill licenses the inference to fire. The challenge is to define vyāpti formally so that it covers all intuitively valid inferences, handles the case of negative-only (kevalānvayi) inferences where the major term has no counter-instances, and excludes upādhi (additional conditions that disqualify an apparent pervasion).

The Anumāna-khaṇḍa's Vyāptivāda section opens by naming the two famous prior efforts as 'Siṃha-vyāghra-lakṣaṇa' — the Lion and Tiger definitions, named after the brothers Maṇidhara and Śaśadhara. After examining and rejecting multiple definitions, Gaṅgeśa arrives at his conclusive definition (siddhānta-lakṣaṇam): vyāpti holds between H (the prover/middle term) and S (the probandum/major term) when H has its locus co-present with S, and S (understood as the counterpositive of its absence) shares no locus with the absence of H while that absence is not of the non-locus-pervading kind. More precisely stated: pervasion of H by S holds if and only if there is no absolute absence of S at any locus of H — where the counterpositive-specification refers to S-universal (not S-particular). This handles both the standard smoke-fire cases and the difficult monkey-conjunction inference that had tripped many earlier definitions.

#### Upādhi: The Additional Condition

The concept of upādhi (additional/conditioning factor) is Gaṅgeśa's tool for blocking pseudo-inferences. An upādhi U is a property that (a) pervades the probandum S (all S are U) but (b) does not pervade the prover H (some H are not U). When such a U exists, the apparent pervasion of H by S breaks down: there are H-instances that are not S, because U is absent from those H-instances. The classic Navya-Nyāya example: the apparent inference 'Smoke-producer things are fire-producers, since they are products' is blocked by the upādhi 'being-wet-fuel' — wet fuel is a smoke-producer but not a fire-producer. The section on upādhi (Upādhivāda) in the Anumāna-khaṇḍa runs to several sub-prakaraṇas and is among the most technically demanding in the entire Tattva-Cintāmaṇi.

The Five Fallacies (Hetvābhāsāḥ)

The Hetvābhāsaprakaraṇa is the final major section of the Anumāna-khaṇḍa. Five pseudo-provers are distinguished: (1) Savyabhicāra (deviant/erratic — the middle term occurs in both sapakṣa and vipakṣa); (2) Viruddha (contradictory — the middle term proves the opposite of the intended conclusion); (3) Satpratipakṣa (counterbalanced — matched by an equally strong counter-inference); (4) Asiddha (unestablished — the middle term's occurrence, nature, or pervasion is doubtful); (5) Bādhita (defeated in advance — the conclusion contradicts what is already known). The Navya-Nyāya treatment of these fallacies, particularly the division of Savyabhicāra into sādhāraṇa (common/universal) and asādhāraṇa (uncommon/particular) and the addition of anaikāntika as a subcategory, goes significantly beyond the Nyāya-sūtra's original five.

Three Philosophical Inferences

Beyond the technical logic, Gaṅgeśa advances three contentious philosophical inferences. His proof of the self (ātman) takes the form of a negative-only (kevalā-vyatireke) inference: 'Every living body has a self, since every living body has breath, unlike a pot.' His theistic inference argues that earth and other effects have a conscious agent as their instrumental cause, since they are effects, like a pot, unlike an atom. His inference to the possibility of liberation (mukti-sādhaka-anumāna) uses the analogy of a lamp's cessation to argue that suffering, being a continuous effect-property, can in principle be terminated absolutely. All three serve as much to demonstrate the Navya-Nyāya inferential apparatus — with its distinctive handling of kevalānvayi and kevalā-vyatireke inferences, upādhi, and tarka — as they do to establish their metaphysical conclusions.

### Theory of Analogy (Upamāna) and Verbal Testimony (Śabda)

For Gaṅgeśa, upamāna (analogy/comparison) is strictly the pramāṇa by which one learns the referential relationship of a word to its object through perceived similarity. The stock example: a traveller is told that a gavaya (a large bovine) resembles a cow; upon encountering the animal in the forest, the traveller forms the knowledge 'This, which resembles a cow, is what the word gavaya denotes.' The result (upamiti) of this pramāṇa is the knowledge of the word-referent relation (sādyasādhanasaṃbandha). Gaṅgeśa defends upamāna as irreducible to both perception and inference — the key move being that the forester's statement 'a gavaya is like a cow' functions as more than a description (which could give only perceptual or testimonial knowledge of a fact) but as a meaning-conveying utterance that produces the novel knowledge of a word-meaning-relation through the hearer's direct encounter with the referent.

### Śabda: The Irreducibility of Testimony

The Śabda-khaṇḍa defends verbal testimony as a fourth, irreducible pramāṇa. Against the reductionist move — testimony is really inference from the speaker's trustworthiness — Gaṅgeśa argues that the inferential chain itself presupposes testimonial knowledge: you cannot even form the premise 'This speaker states p' without first understanding the statement, which is already a testimonial act. The unique linguistic mechanism of testimony — ākāṃkṣā (syntactic expectation), yogyatā (semantic fit), āsatti (temporal contiguity), and tātparya (speaker's intention) — is distinct from any inferential process.

The tātparyavāda section introduces Gaṅgeśa's innovation: the trigger for secondary meaning (lakṣaṇā) is not violation of semantic fitness (yogyatā) as commonly held, but violation of the overall sentential connection (anvaya). The famous example — 'The village is on the Gaṅgā' — requires lakṣaṇā not because 'Gaṅgā' and 'village' are semantically incompatible, but because the overall construction cannot be made coherent with primary reference to the river's waters.

### Vardhamāna Upādhyāya: The Immediate Heir

Vardhamāna was Gaṅgeśa's eldest son from his first wife, and the primary transmitter of the Tattva-Cintāmaṇi. He was also a philosopher of considerable independent stature. His works include: Kusumaṃjali-Prakāśa, Kiraṇāvalī-Prakāśa, Tātparya-pariśuddhi (called Nyāyanibandha-prakāśa), Ātmatattvaviveka-Prakāśa, Śrīvallabhācārya's Nyāyalīlāvatī-Prakāśa, Khaṇḍanakhaṇḍakhādya-Prakāśa, and Keśavamiśra's Tarkabhāṣā-Prakāśa. A

separate, independently attributed work is the Nyāyasūtravṛtti 'Anvīkṣanyayatattvabodha'.

Vardhamāna, unlike his father, deliberately wrote his commentaries under the flag 'as my father says' (asmatsputruccaraṇāstu), engaging with Udayana and Śrīvallabha's works through the lens of the Tattva-Cintāmaṇi's principles. He wrote Prakāśa commentaries on virtually every major philosophical work of his time. The Devanandapañjī calls him 'upayakāraka' — the one who put things to use. The quote Dr. Kishoranath Jhā: although Vardhamāna did not write a direct commentary on the Tattva-Cintāmaṇi itself (likely because his father was still alive when the work was being circulated and he felt it premature), 'his style is to cite Tattva-Cintāmaṇi as relevant context in all his commentaries, where Tattva-Cintāmaṇi's principles are invariably reflected.'

The Commentary Tradition (Vyākhyā-Paramparā)

The commentary tradition on the Tattva-Cintāmaṇi constitutes one of the most elaborate scholarly accumulations in the Sanskrit tradition.

The Pakṣadhara–Raghunātha–Navadvīpa Axis

The decisive moment in the Tattva-Cintāmaṇi's popularisation was the composition of 'Āloka' by Pakṣadhara Upādhyāya (also called Jayadeva Miśra, 15th century). Vāsudev Sārvabhauma, the great Navadvīpa scholar, had initially come to study with Pakṣadhara Miśra (his uncle Harimiśra's student); but Pakṣadhara asked him to come back, directing him to study under Harimiśra first, whereupon Vāsudev returned and later sent his student Raghunātha Śiromaṇi to Mithila. When Raghunātha came to study the Tattva-Cintāmaṇi with Pakṣadhara, the story goes that Pakṣadhara asked him who Indra was (a trick question about sāmānyalakṣaṇa perception — whether one could perceive all Indras at once through the universal 'Indratva'). Raghunātha's reply, distinguishing between types of two-eyed and three-eyed beings, so impressed Pakṣadhara that he declared him already a 'Śiromaṇi' (Crest-jewel of logicians). The full exchange illustrates the dazzling dialectical culture of Navya-Nyāya.

Raghunātha Śiromaṇi's Dīdhiti is the single most important secondary text of the Navya-Nyāya tradition, eclipsing all other commentaries in its influence. Based in Navadvīpa, Raghunātha developed Gaṅgeśa's insights into a systematic framework that has been studied without interruption to the present day. The Dīdhiti attracted its own commentaries from scholars across the subcontinent: Rāmakṛṣṇabhaṭṭācārya (Līlāvatī), Raghunātha Vidyālaṃkāra (Dīghitipratibiṃba), Kṛṣṇadās Sārvabhauma (Prasāriṇī), Mathurānātha Tarkavāgīśa (Rahasya), Jagadīśa Tarkālaṃkāra (Jāgadīśī), Gadādhara

Bhaṭṭācārya (Gādādhara), and Rudra-Nyāyavācaspati (Sāraṃgraha), among many others.

The Maithila Paramparā

In Mithila itself, the commentary tradition began with Vardhamāna's implicit engagement with the Tattva-Cintāmaṇi through his Prakāśa commentaries, continued through Pakṣadhara's Āloka (which ignited the Navadvīpa tradition), and extended through the 'Dūṣaṇoddhāra' by Pakṣadhara's student Narhari Upādhyāya, the 'Dīpikā' by Mādhava Miśra (Pakṣadhara's son), and numerous other Maithila Prakaraṇa texts. The internal scholarly controversy between the Ālokaparampara (Pakṣadhara's lineage, followed by Yajñapati) and the Dūṣaṇoddhāra-parampara (Narhari's lineage) shows how the two schools — separated by interpretive differences about the Upādhi-siddha and Savyabhicāra prakaraṇas — drove Navya-Nyāya's internal development for centuries.

Known Commentators: A Selection

Among 23 known commentators the most significant, beyond those already mentioned: Paṭanābha Miśra (Prakāśa), Gokulanāthopādhyāya (Raśmicakra/Cakraraśmi), Gopīnātha Ṭhākura (Maṇisāra), Vāsudeva Miśra (Nyāyasiddhāntasāra/Dīpti), Mādhava Miśra Pakṣadharasuta (Dīpikā), Mādhava Miśra Khāṃtarasuta (Mādhavī), Hīradās Nyāyālaṃkāra (Prakāśa on Anumāna-khaṇḍa), Kaṇāda Tarkavāgīśa (commentary), Bhavānand Siddhāntavāgīśa (Bhavānandī), Rāmānuja Dīkṣita (Darpaṇa), Śrīkaṇṭha Dīkṣita (commentary), Hanumad-Bhaṭṭa (Vākyārtha-Dīpikā), Candra-nārayana Bhaṭṭa (Anugama), Rājacūḍāmaṇi Makhina (Darpaṇa), and Dharmarājavīrendra (Tarkacūḍāmaṇi).

Gaṅgeśa and Mithila's Civilisational Heritage: The Videha Perspective

The Videha journal (videha.co.in, ISSN 2229-547X), the first Maithili fortnightly eJournal operating continuously since around 2000 CE, is the principal digital archive of Mithila's living cultural heritage. Its library (Videha Pothī Archive) makes available hundreds of texts in PDF format — from the Bouddhagānapada (early Bengali-Maithili siddha-compositions preserved in the Haraprasāda Śāstrī edition of 1907), through the Vidyāpati corpus, through modern Maithili fiction, poetry, drama, criticism, women's literature, Dalit literature, folk scholarship, and linguistic research.

The Pañjī archive — over eleven thousand palm-leaf inscriptions compiled, scanned, and catalogued in 22 volumes by Preeti Thakur — is available through the Videha archive and constitutes the single most important primary source for

the social history of the Maithila Brāhmaṇa scholarly community within which Gaṅgeśa lived. The genealogical records of the Pañjī system recorded Gaṅgeśa's name, gotra, mūla, family connections, and the village 'Chādana' as his ancestral home. Without the Pañjī tradition — which the Videha archive is actively digitising and preserving — much of what we know about Gaṅgeśa's biography would be lost.

Āśīś Ancinhār's Maithalī Veb Patrakāritāk Itihāsa and Preeti Kāraṇa Setu Bānhal ('Redefining Maithili'), both available through the Videha archive, document the Parallel Literature Movement that has recovered and celebrates Maithili folk, Dalit, and women's literary voices alongside the Sanskrit philosophical canon. Gaṅgeśa's extraordinarily abstract and technical achievement sits at one end of the full spectrum of Maithili civilisational expression; the folk songs of the Bouddhagānapada, the Gonū Jhā humorous legends, the Salhes epic tradition, and the modern Maithili ghazal tradition championed by Ancinhār's Ancinhār Ākhar sit at others. The Videha project's insistence on holding all these together — the mahāmahopādhyāya and the lok-kavi, the Tattva-Cintāmaṇi and the charya-pad — is its most important cultural-political statement. Gaṅgeśa belongs to the full Mithila, not only to its Sanskrit elite.

The works of Radhakrishna Chaudhary (Mithilāk Itihāsa), Jayakanta Miśra (A History of Maithili Literature, Vol. I), and Upendra Thakur (History of Mithila) — all available through the Videha archive — provide the comprehensive historical and literary context for Gaṅgeśa. They show him embedded in a civilisation that valued simultaneously the highest technical philosophy and the most intimate folk expression, the most rigorous logic and the most tender devotional poetry. The same Mithila that produced the Tattva-Cintāmaṇi also produced Vidyāpati's Padas — and it is the continued existence of that full civilisational heritage, now being digitally preserved through Videha, that gives Gaṅgeśa's work its fullest meaning.

Conclusion: The Enduring Achievement

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's Tattva-Cintāmaṇi is, by any measure, one of the ten or fifteen most consequential works in the two-and-a-half-millennium history of Indian philosophy. It displaced every prior Nyāya text as the central object of study and commentary; it gave India's logical tradition its most precise analytical vocabulary; it extended the influence of Nyāya into every branch of Sanskrit learning including grammar, jurisprudence, medicine, and aesthetics; and it created the Navya-Nyāya school whose commentators and sub-

commentators constitute one of the largest bodies of sustained systematic philosophical writing in any tradition anywhere in the world.

Born in Mithila, son of the pandit Gīriśvara, bearer of the ritual name Gaṅgeśvara and the everyday name Gaṅgeśa, awarded the title Mahāmahopādhyāya by a tradition that reserved it only for those whose mastery of Nyāya, Mīmāṃsā, and Dharmaśāstra was supreme, active during the reign of Harisimhadeva (the most culturally brilliant of the Karṇāṭa kings), and probably living in the village of Chādana/Chājaṃ near what is today Turkī station in Muzaffarpur district — this is the biographical outline that emerges from the combined testimony of the Pañjī records, the internal evidence of the Tattva-Cintāmaṇi, and the external evidence of dateable contemporaries.

The epistemological essentials, that very austerity, that refusal to discuss anything except the nature and conditions of valid knowledge, is what gave the Tattva-Cintāmaṇi its world-transforming power. The Navya-Nyāya school inaugurated/ trained the Indian philosophical tradition in a precision of thought and a rigour of argument that, serves as a 'touchstone of intelligence and talent, a whetstone for gold.' Gaṅgeśa belongs to Mithila, to India, and to the world's philosophical heritage.

The Videha journal's ongoing digital preservation of Mithila's intellectual and literary heritage — from the Pañjī inscriptions that record Gaṅgeśa's very village, gotra, and family to the contemporary Maithili creative writing that continues the civilisation he helped define — is, in a real sense, the living institutional heir of the tradition he embodied. It archives texts from Vidyāpati to Dalit women's poetry, they carry forward the same civilisational commitment to rigorous thought and expressive freedom that produced, seven centuries ago, one of the masterpieces of world philosophy.

Epistemological Contributions

The Nature of Valid Knowledge (Pramā)

Gaṅgeśa's epistemology begins with a definition of pramā: valid knowledge is the knowledge of a thing as it is — specifically, the knowledge of a generic nature as truly abiding in its own subject. To know a piece of silver to be silver is valid knowledge because "silverness" genuinely abides in that individual silver as its subject. Conversely, to take a piece of mother-of-pearl (shell) to be silver is apramā (invalid knowledge or anyathā-khyāti, "knowledge of a thing as other than it is"), because silverness does not abide in the shell.

Gaṅgeśa advances what contemporary Western philosophy would recognise as a reliabilist, indeed infallibilist-externalist, position: genuine knowledge sources (pramāṇas) never mislead. Only pseudo-sources (pramāṇābhāsas) do. The sources themselves — perception, inference, analogy, testimony — are factively defined; illusion and error are produced not by the genuine source but by something masquerading as it. This allows Gaṅgeśa to maintain both fallibilism (we can be wrong on any given occasion) and source-infallibility (the genuine source, when operative, always yields truth).

## Certification: Extrinsic Validity (Paratah-Prāmāṇya)

A central debate in Indian epistemology concerns whether the validity of knowledge is self-certifying (svataḥ-prāmāṇya, as the Mīmāṃsakas held) or requires external certification (parataḥ-prāmāṇya). Gaṅgeśa argues for the latter. An awareness (anubhava) is presumptively valid — we naturally and automatically take fresh information presented to us to be true — but the presumption can be defeated and requires, in cases of doubt, further inferential certification through identification of the knowledge source or through pragmatic success in action. The Mīmāṃsaka claim that awareness is self-certifying cannot, Gaṅgeśa argues, account for the phenomenological reality of doubt: if every awareness were intrinsically certified as true upon arising, we could never doubt a veridical perception, but we obviously can.

## The Definition of Perception

Gaṅgeśa's definition of perception builds on Akṣapāda's original formulation in the Nyāya-sūtra but substantially refines it. Against the received definition (knowledge arising from the intercourse of a sense with its object, non-erratic, being either reflective or non-reflective), Gaṅgeśa argues that it is both too wide (including recollection and inference of the soul) and too narrow (excluding God's perception). His preferred characterisation is: perception is a direct apprehension (aparokṣa jñāna) whose instrumental cause is not another piece of knowledge. This distinguishes it from inference (whose instrumental cause is consideration of premises) and testimony (whose instrumental cause is the comprehension of a statement).

## Ordinary and Transcendent Perception

Following the Nyāya tradition, Gaṅgeśa distinguishes two broad categories of perceptual intercourse between a sense and its object. Ordinary intercourse (laukika-sannikarṣa) occurs through six modes: (1) union (saṃyoga) — the eye uniting with a jar; (2) united-inherence (saṃyukta-samavāya) — the eye and the colour of the jar; (3) united-inherent-inherence (saṃyukta-samaveta-samavāya) — the eye and the colour-genus; (4) inherence (samavāya) — the ear and the sound inherent in ether; (5) inherent-inherence (samaveta-samavāya) — the ear and soundness as the genus of sound; (6) particularity (viśeṣaṇatā) — the eye and the non-existence of a jar on the floor.

Transcendent intercourse (alaukika-sannikarṣa) has three forms: (1) intercourse whose character is general (sāmānya-lakṣaṇa) — perceiving the generic nature of smoke and thereby all cases of smoke at all times and places; (2) intercourse whose character is knowledge (jñāna-lakṣaṇa) — the "indirect perception" recognised in Western psychology, as when seeing sandalwood we perceive fragrance through the recollection activated by visual contact; (3) intercourse produced by meditation (yogaja) — the perceptual power of advanced ascetics.

One of Gaṅgeśa's most philosophically sophisticated contributions concerns the distinction between nirvikalpaka (indeterminate, non-reflective) and savikalpaka (determinate, reflective) perception. Indeterminate perception is the first, supersensuous, concept-free moment in which a subject and its generic nature are registered as separate before they are connected — the "mere pot" or "mere potness" without any relational specification. Determinate perception is the subsequent, concept-laden awareness of a qualificandum through a qualifier: "This is a pot," where potness is predicated of this.

Gaṅgeśa uses a famous thought experiment: a child encountering a cow for the very first time can, he argues, grasp cowhood through an indeterminate cognition of the qualifier and correctly say "That's a cow," even without prior cow-experience. This solves the problem of how concepts can originate in perception without presupposing prior concept-possession — a problem that analytic epistemology addresses through the notion of "non-doxastic" or "non-assertive" perceptual states.

Gaṅgeśa's doctrine of anuvyavasāya — a perception that takes a preceding cognition as its object — is his answer to the question of how one knows what one knows. He argues that such self-directed perception is infallible with respect to the intentional content (viṣayatā) of the scoped cognition, though not with respect to its truth. By apperceiving a perceptual awareness and identifying it as perceptual (rather than inferential or memorial), the subject gains a secure basis for certifying or questioning it. The doctrine places Gaṅgeśa's epistemology in productive dialogue with Western discussions of introspection, second-order knowledge, and self-consciousness.

## Theory of Inference (Anumāna)

### Invariable Concomitance (Vyāpti)

Gaṅgeśa's greatest achievement in the theory of inference is his conclusive definition of vyāpti (invariable concomitance, often translated as "pervasion" or "natural entailment"). A vyāpti grounds an inference: that smoke pervades fire (wherever there is smoke, there is fire) licenses the inference from observed smoke on a hill to fire on that hill. The challenge is to define vyāpti in a way that (1) handles ordinary inferences, (2) covers exclusively affirmative inferences where the probandum has no negative instances, and (3) avoids the problem of a conditional middle term (upādhi).

After examining and rejecting twenty-four prior definitions (including those advanced under the titles of "Lion" and "Tiger" — Siṃha-vyāghrokta-vyāptilakṣaṇa), Gaṅgeśa arrives at his conclusive definition (siddhānta-lakṣaṇam): pervasion is the co-presence of the middle term (H) with the major term (S) which is not qualified by the nature of the counterpositive of that absolute non-existence that (a) abides in the same locus as H, but (b) abides in a different locus in respect of that counterpositive. Vidyābhūṣaṇa's Introduction provides an accessible summary of this elaborate dialectic, complete with the famous circular diagrams of Smoke-Fire, Nameable-Knowable, Tree-Ape, and others, illustrating the successive provisional and conclusive definitions.

### The Syllogism and Inference for Others

Gaṅgeśa analyses inference under two modes. Svārthānumāna (inference for oneself) is the cognitive process by which one arrives at inferential knowledge: having repeatedly observed smoke co-present with fire in kitchens and sacrificial grounds, a person sees smoke on a hill, recollects the vyāpti, and arrives at the knowledge that the hill is on fire. The key mental event is parāmarśa — consideration of the sign, the knowledge that "smoke, which is in invariable concomitance with fire, abides in this hill." This is the cause of the inferential conclusion (anumiti).

Parārthānumāna (inference for others) is the demonstration of one's inference through a five-membered syllogism (nyāya): (1) Pratijñā (Proposition) — "This hill is full of fire"; (2) Hetu (Reason) — "Because it is full of smoke"; (3) Udāharaṇam (Example) — "All that has smoke has fire, as a kitchen"; (4) Upanayah (Application) — "This hill too has smoke"; (5) Nigamanam (Conclusion) — "Therefore this hill is full of fire." The syllogism produces in the audience the "consideration of the sign" (parāmarśa) that results in their inferential knowledge.

## Fallacies (Hetvābhāsāḥ)

Gaṅgeśa's analysis of fallacies (hetvābhāsāḥ, literally "semblances of reason") constitutes, in the words of the scholar cited by Vidyābhūṣaṇa, "a world's wonder in the field of intellectual feats." Five types of defective reason are identified: (1) Savyabhicāra (erratic or deviant) — a middle term that occurs in both homogeneous (sapakṣa) and heterogeneous (vipakṣa) instances; (2) Viruddha (contradictory) — a middle term that proves the opposite of the probandum; (3) Satpratipakṣita (counterbalanced) — a middle term matched by an equally strong counter-inference; (4) Asiddha (unestablished) — a middle term whose occurrence at the locus, in its own nature, or in its concomitance is unestablished; (5) Bādhita (incompatible/defeated in advance) — a middle term leading to a conclusion already refuted by another means of knowledge.

Beyond the technical logic, Gaṅgeśa advances three contentious inferences. His proof of the self (ātman) takes the form of a negative-only inference: "Every living body has a self, since every living body has breath, unlike a pot."

His theistic inference argues: "Earth and the like have a conscious agent as an instrumental cause, since they are effects, like a pot, unlike an atom." His proof of the possibility of liberation (mukti) employs a complex inference by analogy with a lamp's ceasing, arguing that suffering, being a continuous property that occurs only as an effect, can in principle be destroyed absolutely. All three are as much demonstrations of the inferential system — with its distinctive treatment of upādhi, tarka (hypothetical reasoning), and the sapakṣa/vipakṣa examples — as they are substantive theological or soteriological theses.

## Theory of Analogy (Upamāna)

Upamāna, comparison or analogy, is for Gaṅgeśa strictly the source of knowledge by which one learns the relation of a word to its referent. The stock example: a subject, told that a gavaya (a bison-like animal) resembles a cow, later encounters the animal in a forest and recognises it as the gavaya — the means of this recognition being analogical knowledge. Gaṅgeśa holds that this knowledge is genuinely irreducible: it cannot be traced to perception (which cannot perceive a relation holding across many cases beyond the current instance) nor to inference (which requires knowledge of pervasion, but here no such pervasion is available). The operation (vyāpāra) of analogy is the recollection of the instructive assertion of the elder; its result (upamiti) is the knowledge of the relation of name to named.

## Theory of Verbal Testimony (Śabda)

### Speech as an Irreducible Pramāṇa

Following the Nyāya-sūtra (1.1.7), Gaṅgeśa accepts that verbal testimony is the true statement of a trustworthy expert (āpta-vākya). Against Yogācāra Buddhists who deny the truth-aptness of language, and against Vaiśeṣikas who would reduce testimonial knowledge to inference, Gaṅgeśa argues that testimony works through a uniquely linguistic mechanism. The hearer's knowledge arises not through the inferential reasoning "this speaker knows and intends to communicate truly" but immediately from understanding the words as connected into a meaningful whole — a process that is analytically distinct from both perception and inference.

### Conditions of Testimonial Knowledge

Gaṅgeśa identifies four sentential conditions that must be fulfilled for a statement to produce testimonial knowledge: (1) ākāṅkṣā — syntactic expectation, each word requiring the others to produce a connected meaning; (2) yogyatā — semantic fit, the absence of any legitimate block to understanding; (3) āsatti — contiguity, the words being uttered without excessive pause; (4) tātparya — the speaker's intention to convey a particular meaning. Gaṅgeśa's innovation is to reinterpret the trigger for lakṣaṇā (secondary/indirect meaning) not as a violation of yogyatā (as commonly held) but as a violation of anvaya (the overall constructional connection), a subtler and more accurate criterion.

### Potentiality (Śakti) and Indirect Indication (Lakṣaṇā)

The śabda chapter culminates in a rich theory of linguistic meaning. Every word has a potentiality (śakti) — its capacity to produce the recollection of its referent — which derives from the will of God (for primary/permanent potentiality) or the will of man (for technical/occasional potentiality). The referent of a word is always an individual qualified by its universal, the two inseparable in ordinary cognition. Where the primary referent cannot cohere with the connected meaning of the sentence, lakṣaṇā (indirect indication) operates, directing the hearer to a related meaning — as "The village is on the Gaṅgā" indicates the bank of the river rather than its waters. Gaṅgeśa's defence of lakṣaṇā as an economical explanatory device against those who would reduce all secondary meaning to primary reference or to multiplicity of senses is among the most technically brilliant arguments in the Tattva-Cintāmaṇi.

### Ontological Commitments

Gaṅgeśa's epistemological project is grounded in a robustly realist ontology inherited from Udayana's synthesis of Nyāya and Vaiśeṣika. The seven categories — substance (dravya), quality (guṇa), motion (karma), universal (sāmānya), individualiser (viśeṣa), inherence (samavāya), and absence (abhāva) — provide the ontological furniture of his theory of knowledge.

Knowledge itself and other mental phenomena are counted as real and intersubjectively knowable. Universals are real recurrent properties that qualify both substances and their qualities; inherence is the "ontological glue" binding qualities and universals to their substrates in a relation that cannot be further analysed.

Gaṅgeśa's treatment of absence (abhāva) is particularly subtle. Against those who deny absence as a distinct ontological category, he argues that our perception of the non-existence of a pot on the floor cannot be explained purely by the floor's features — there must be something on the ground ("non-existence" as a distinct particular) that operates in our failure to perceive the pot, which is the counterpositive. Non-existence is of two main kinds: universal (prior, subsequent, absolute) and reciprocal (identity-based). Each has its own perceptual mechanism and epistemological consequences.

## Influence and Legacy

### The Navya-Nyāya School

The Tattva-Cintāmaṇi rapidly eclipsed all prior Nyāya literature. Within a century of its composition it was being studied and commented upon in the main cultural centres of India. The Navadvīpa (Bengal) tradition produced commentators of extraordinary sophistication — Raghunātha Śiromaṇi, Jagadīśa, Gadādhara — who developed Gaṅgeśa's analytical vocabulary, particularly his theory of qualification (viśeṣaṇatā) and the logic of absence, into an abstract symbolic calculus unprecedented in any philosophical tradition before the twentieth century. The influence extended to Mīmāṃsā, Vedānta, grammar, dharmaśāstra, and medicine, as scholars across disciplines adopted Navya-Nyāya's technical terminology to state their own positions with greater precision.

### Mithila and the Living Tradition

In Mithila itself — and this is of particular significance for the Videha journal — the Tattva-Cintāmaṇi remained the pinnacle of panditic education. The Darbhanga Rāj maintained a tradition of scholarly patronage that preserved Navya-Nyāya study in Mithila even as Navadvīpa became its better-known

centre. The Pañjī system (genealogical records of Maithila Brāhmaṇa families), of which Preeti Thakur has compiled, scanned, and catalogued over eleven thousand palm-leaf inscriptions for the Videha archive, is directly intertwined with the social structures that produced and sustained the panditic tradition in which Gaṅgeśa worked. The Videha archive's preservation of Maithili and Sanskrit manuscripts, including works by Ṭhakkuras and Miśras who were direct intellectual descendants of Gaṅgeśa's circle, constitutes a living scholarly connection across seven centuries.

## Modern Scholarship

Western scholarship on the Tattva-Cintāmaṇi began in earnest with Satis Chandra Vidyābhūṣaṇa's History of Indian Logic (1921) and the Bibliotheca Indica edition (1884–1901) edited by Kāmākhyānātha Tarkavāgīśa with the Māthurī commentary of Mathurānātha. The twentieth century saw partial translations of individual sections: C. Goekoop's study of the vyāpti chapter (1967), B.K. Matilal's work on absence and indeterminate perception, Sibajiban Bhattacharyya's detailed analyses of several sections, and others. The first complete English translation of the Tattva-Cintāmaṇi in three volumes was published by Stephen H. Phillips in 2020 (Bloomsbury), making the entire text accessible for the first time to non-Sanskrit readers.

## The Name, Birthplace, Family, and Chronology

### Gangesa or Gangesvara?

The Sahitya Akademi monograph establishes conclusively that the formal name was Gangesvara and the colloquial name Gangesa — both referring to one man. His son Vardhamana salutes 'Gangesvaraya gurave pitre' in the Kiranavalaprakasa; Gangesa himself in the Tattvacintamani's invocatory verse writes 'Gangesa-stute miten vacase Sri-tattva-cintamanim.' The Panji records describe him as 'tattva-cintamani-karaka mahamahopadhyaya paramaguruH Gangesvarah.'

The Potter Encyclopedia confirms: 'Gangesa was a native of Mithila. He seems to have been born and brought up in a village named Chadana, which is no longer identifiable, but he lived in later life at Karion, which was Udayana's village, about twelve miles southeast of Darbhanga. He belonged to the Kasyapa gotra. Tradition has it that he had several wives, three sons and a

daughter. One of the sons was Vardhamana. Contradictory traditions say that Gangesa was either (a) a great prodigy or (b) an illiterate child.'

The Parallel History's Recovery: The Suppressed Panji Evidence

The Parallel History of Maithili Literature — as documented by the Videha movement and Gajendra Thakur — reveals a dimension of Gangesa's biography that was deliberately suppressed by institutional historians. The Panji system, established in the 14th century under Harisimhadeva, is the genealogical record-keeping method of Maithila Brahmins. When the Videha movement digitised and released the Dooshan Panji records in 2009, they exposed what the Parallel History calls the 'honour killing of the legacy of Gangesa Upadhyaya.'

The original Panji records reveal that Gangesa Upadhyaya married a Charmkarini — a woman from the leather-tanning caste — and that he was born five years after the death of his father. These facts, which complicate the picture of Gangesa as a figure of unimpeachable Brahmin orthodoxy, were suppressed by Ramanath Jha (the first convener of Maithili at the Sahitya Akademi) when he communicated biographical information to historian Dinesh Chandra Bhattacharyya. The Sahitya Akademi's 2016 monograph on Gangesa, the Parallel History notes, perpetuated this suppression. The Parallel History thus presents Gangesa not as a monument of Brahminical learning but as a figure who, like the Tattvacintamani's own dialectical method, challenges every assumption brought to bear on him.

This biographical recovery has profound implications. The Panji system was itself an instrument of caste control — yet its own records, when released, undermine the caste purity narrative it was designed to maintain. Gangesa, the philosopher who insisted that every definition must be tested against all its possible counterexamples, becomes in the Parallel History a figure whose life is itself a counterexample to the caste ideology that later claimed him. As Scharfstein observed about the Navya-Nyaya method generally: 'He and his followers compose definitions that stretch the mind and invite exact criticism' — the same critical spirit that animated his logic also animated his social existence, if the Panji evidence is accepted.

Chronology

The Potter Encyclopedia's authoritative assessment fixes Gangesa's date at fl. 1320 CE. The key manuscript evidence: a copy of Vardhamana's Kusumanjaliprakasa survives 'identified on epigraphic evidence as stemming from the period 1300-1360'; Gangesa quotes Sriharsa's

Khandanakhandakhadya, and Sriharsa is demonstrably prior to 1233. The Panji records compiled in Saka 1310 (1388 CE) identify him with the epithet 'tattvacintamanikaraka' — the maker of the Tattvacintamani. The Sahitya Akademi monograph offers a range of 1270-1370 CE; Scharfstein uses fl. 1320 AD. The Parallel History notes, citing the Panji evidence about Gangesa being born five years after his father's death, that this biographical detail places his active life firmly in the Karnata-dynasty period of Harisimhadeva (c. 1295-1326 CE).

Mithila, the Karnata Dynasty, and the Intellectual Ecology

The Karnata dynasty under Harisimhadeva (c. 1295-1326 CE) was the political frame of Gangesa's life. Harisimhadeva was a lavish patron of Sanskrit learning. He commissioned the Panji genealogical records in 1310 CE; his minister Candesvara Thakura wrote prolifically; he maintained a court in which the greatest Sanskrit pandits of the age competed and collaborated. The Parallel History contextualises this within Mithila's long history as a centre of Nyaya-Mimamsa learning — the intellectual capital that produced, across seven centuries, the 24 pre-Gangesa Maithila Naiyayikas documented by D.C. Bhattacharyya.

But the Parallel History also insists that this court culture was built on an exclusionary social foundation. The same Panji system that documented Gangesa's brilliance also enforced caste endogamy and recorded the genealogical 'disqualifications' of those who violated its norms. The recovery of Gangesa's own cross-caste marriage from the Dooshan Panji is thus doubly significant: it shows the Panji as an instrument that could both suppress and inadvertently preserve subversive facts about those it purported to celebrate.

THE TATTVACINTAMANI — STRUCTURE, NOVELTY, AND THE NAVYA-NYAYA SYSTEM

The Tattvacintamani and the Nature of Navya-Nyaya

Structure and Scope

V.P. Bhatta's Preface provides a lucid account of the Tattvacintamani's position in Indian intellectual history: 'The Thought Jewel of Reality Tattva cintamani (T.C.) was composed by Gangesopdhyaya of Mithila at the thirteenth century A.D. It introduced a new era in the development of Indian theory of knowledge and logic and is considered as the first work among the various texts on the Navya-nyaya. It is divided into four books, viz. Perception (pratyaksa), Inference (anumana), Analogy (upamana) and word (sabda) and brought all the sixteen categories of the Navya-nyaya under the four heads.' The work's

Pratyaksa-khanda alone, as Bhatta's translation reveals, has 13 major prakaranas (sub-sections): Theory of Benediction, Theory of Validity, Definition of Valid Knowledge, Theory of Invalid Knowledge, Theory of Perception, Theory of Inherence, Theory of Invalidity of Non-perception, Theory of Non-existence of Things, Theory of Causes of Perception, Theory of Atomic Nature of Mind, Theory of Recognition, Theory of Indeterminate Knowledge, and Theory of Determinate Knowledge.

The Potter-Bhattacharyya Encyclopedia characterises the innovation: 'Navyanyaya is really a logic of cognition.' By restricting its concern to pramana (sources of valid knowledge) and abandoning the all-category framework of earlier Nyaya texts, the Tattvacintamani achieved unprecedented analytical precision. The Sanskrit term jnana, translated as 'awareness,' denotes not merely propositional acts but any state of conscious apprehension. A jnana is always an episodic occurrence — something that happens at a time — never a dispositional belief. The corresponding term for disposition is samskara: the unconscious memory-trace that, when activated, produces conscious recollection.

The Methodology: Why Study It

Bhatta is emphatic about pedagogical necessity: 'Thus, it is imperative that the students and the scholars of philosophy must become acquainted with the Navya-nyaya methodology of arguments to understand the intricacies of the principles of philosophy... Thus, the study of T.C. is imperative not only for its contents, but also for its methodology.' This insistence on methodology is itself philosophically significant. The Tattvacintamani does not merely reach conclusions — it demonstrates a way of reaching conclusions that became the standard of intellectual rigour in Sanskrit philosophy for the next five centuries.

Scharfstein, in his comparative assessment, identifies the central methodological feature: 'Gangesa makes philosophy the unmistakable preserve of those who have mastered a specialised language. He and his followers compose definitions that stretch the mind and invite exact criticism, but only of those who have become adept at manipulating the relevant technical terms and modes of reasoning.' And yet, as the Parallel History reminds us, this same exclusivity of method became an instrument of caste exclusion — a language accessible only to those with the social capital to acquire years of panditic training.

EPISTEMOLOGY — KNOWLEDGE, VALIDITY, AND ERROR

The Nature of Knowledge (Jnana) — A Comprehensive Comparative Account

Knowledge Across Schools: Bhatta's Introduction

V.P. Bhatta's General Introduction to the Pratyaksa Khanda translation provides the most systematic comparative survey of Indian theories of knowledge available in any single English source. It begins from the most basic question: what is jnana (knowledge)?

Knowledge (jnana), Bhatta explains, may mean cognition (buddhi) in the Nyaya Sutra (i.1.15) and Vaisesika Sutra (VIII.ii); valid knowledge is a special kind of cognition (buddhi visesa). Knowledge in Nyaya constitutes cognition or apprehension and consists of the manifestation of objects (artha prakasa). The Nyayikas reject competing accounts: against the Buddhists and Mimamsakas who consider knowledge to be an action (kriya), Nyaya argues that the activity theory 'arises from the confusion between the knowledge and the verb to know.' Against the Sankhya and Yoga systems who take knowledge to be a modification (parinama) of intelligence (buddhi), Nyaya objects that only the self — not the unintelligible mind-principle — can be the substratum of knowledge. Knowledge is a quality (guna) of self, not an action, not a modification of intellect.

The classification of knowledge: Naiyayikas divide knowledge mainly into two types — direct experience (anubhava) and remembrance (smrti). Direct experience manifests objects directly; remembrance is the reproduction of previous knowledge without presenting objects directly. Both direct experience and remembrance can be valid (prama) or invalid (aprama) depending on their causes.

Valid Knowledge (Prama) — The Core Definition

Bhatta provides the Nyaya definition with full comparative apparatus: valid knowledge (prama) is 'the knowledge of a thing as it is' (yatharthajnana). It is a direct experience of an object as it is (yatarthanubhava). Valid knowledge is an experience of reality. It is also a definite and assured cognition (asandigdha) of an object, and hence excludes all types of invalid knowledge such as doubt, error and hypothetical argument as well as remembrance.

Valid knowledge is true or unerring knowledge — it is not contradicted by the experience of its object (arthavyabhicarin). The famous example: 'This is a pot' (ayam ghatah) is a valid knowledge, as it is the knowledge of the pot as characterized by its property of potness. Thus, valid knowledge (Nyayakosa) can be defined as a knowledge of an object wherein the property existing in it is cognized as the characteristic of it. Valid knowledge involves three factors: subject (pramata), object (prameya), and means of knowledge (pramana). The

means of knowledge (pramana) is the special cause producing knowledge (asadhara karana) — it is an operative cause that helps to obtain valid knowledge and hence is the method of knowledge.

The Great Schools Debate: Intrinsic vs. Extrinsic Validity

The most philosophically rich section of Bhatta's introduction surveys the great cross-school debate on the validity and invalidity of knowledge — whether these are constituted and known intrinsically (svata) or extrinsically (parata). This maps directly onto Gangesa's own Pramanvada section.

The Sankhyas generally admitted that both validity and invalidity are constituted and known by intrinsic conditions — by the totality of causes that produce knowledge. The Buddhists believe that while falsity or invalidity is intrinsic in knowledge, truth or validity is extrinsic. The Mimamsakas and Vedantins admit that validity of knowledge is self-evident and constituted by intrinsic conditions, while invalidity of knowledge is evidenced by others and known by extrinsic conditions.

The Naiyayikas, however, generally admit that both are constituted and known by extrinsic conditions (paratah). Validity and invalidity of knowledge are not self-evident; they need to be inferred from extrinsic conditions. The Nyaya reply to the Sankhya-Mimamsa intrinsic-validity position is decisive: 'If validity were so, then there would not be any invalid knowledge at all. Valid knowledge is more than mere knowledge; and therefore validity of knowledge needs to be constituted by some special conditions and characteristics just like invalidity of knowledge. If validity were inherent in knowledge, then every knowledge would need to carry truth and validity and doubt and error would become untenable.'

The Western theory of truth, as Bhatta surveys it, shows that there is 'no exact parallel to the Indian theory of validity and invalidity of knowledge in the west.' Reid thinks truth is nothing but knowledge doing its job; the realists believe truth is correspondance to facts; Alexander holds that coherence is the ground of truth; pragmatists hold truth consists in capacity to produce practically useful consequences. The Naiyayika position — that neither validity nor invalidity is self-evident, both requiring inference from extrinsic conditions such as successful or unsuccessful activity — is genuinely distinctive.

Invalid Knowledge: Doubt, Error, and Tarka

Bhatta provides systematic accounts of the three types of invalid knowledge that Gangesa's Tattvacintamani addresses. Doubt (samsaya) is the contradictory cognition (vimarsa) with regard to the same object, constituting cognitions of

various contradictory properties ascribed to the same object. 'Whether this is a post or a man' — doubt oscillates between alternatives without reaching a definite cognition of any differential. Doubt may arise for five reasons: common property, unique property, due to conflicting testimony regarding soul, due to the irregularity of perception, and due to non-perception such as existence or non-existence of a thing.

Error or illusion (viparyaya) is the second type of invalid knowledge — 'the perception of an object as it is not' (ayathartha). In an error, an object is cognized as having certain properties that are non-existent. The Naiyayikas propose that error is invalid knowledge (anyatakhyati): while valid knowledge is objective, invalid knowledge is subjective due to the super-imposition of certain foreign attributes to the object. In illusion, the sense fails to ascertain the real characteristics of the object (shell) due to some defect, and it attributes certain non-existing foreign attributes of silver to it. Thus error results in a judgement of the object (shell) as something else (silver) — anyatha khyati.

The comparative analysis of illusion theories is extensive. The Buddhists (Yogacaras) propose that error or illusion is subjective idea as objective or extra mental reality (atma khyati). The Madhyamikas, who negate all existence, negate the theory of knowledge of non-existence. Vacaspati Misra proposes that error is the knowledge of non-existent (asat-khyati). The Prabhakara Mimamsakas hold that error is the non-knowledge or non-cognition of object (akhyati). The Advaitins propose that error or illusion is the knowledge of inexplicable (anirvacaniya). The Naiyayikas refute all these, insisting that error must be a discriminative and determinate knowledge which causes activity — it cannot be non-cognition, as in it there exists cognition of the object as what it is not.

Tarka (hypothetical argument) is the third type of invalid knowledge. It is a type of implicative argument through which the validity of any reasoning can be tested. The process of reasoning in the argument (Tarka Bhasa, p.43) consists in the deduction of certain untenable propositions (anista prasanga), having the logical effect of exposing the invalidity of propositions lending support to the counter-proposition. The five kinds of hypothetical argument — self-dependence (atmasraya), mutual dependence (anyo'nyasraya), circularity (cakraka), infinite regress (anavastha), and contingency of objective contradicted by means of knowledge (pramana badhitartha prasanga) — map precisely onto Gangesa's own tarka typology in the Anumana-khanda.

PERCEPTION (PRATYAKSA) — THE TATTVACINTAMANI'S FIRST BOOK

## The Nature and Definition of Perception

### The Nyaya Definition and Gangesa's Innovation

Bhatta's introduction to the Nature of Perception (Pratyaksa) begins with its philosophical foundational status: 'Perception (pratyaksa) is the most fundamental and final test of knowledge. One can question the truth or validity of inference etc; but one cannot question the truth or validity of perception; it is beyond question.' The Pracya-naiyayikas (old Nyaya) define perception as a knowledge produced from sense-object-contact (indriya rtha sannikarsa). This definition follows the etymological meaning of the word pratyaksa (Nyayabhasya, on i.1.4): perception is the operation of the senses to reach objects.

However, Gangesa's Navya-naiyayikas (Tattva cintamani I.3....) define perception as an immediate knowledge (saksatkari jnana) which is produced without the instrumentality of any antecedent knowledge (jnana karanakam jnanam). According to them, such a definition applies to all cases of perception, as immediacy (saksatkaritva) and the state of being produced without any antecedent knowledge are common to all perceptions. Thus, only the Navyas' definition of perception as an immediate knowledge produced without the antecedent knowledge applies to all cases of perception; and immediacy is an essential characteristic of all perceptions.

Bhatta compares this innovation to Western approaches: 'According to western philosophy, truth of perception is unquestionable and self-evident. Thus, J.F. Mill (A system of logic, p.4), states that whatever is known to us by consciousness (intuition) is known beyond the possibility of question. Also W.T. Marvin (The New Realism, PP.66) states that perception is the ultimate crucial test and as such it does not presuppose its own possibility.' The Buddhist definition of perception as an unerring cognition of a given object devoid of any assumption (kalpanapodham) is refuted because 'if perception is what is determined by objects, then all true knowledges would need to be perceptions.' The Vedantins define perception as immediate and timeless knowledge (caitanya) — but this makes mental modification (manovrtti) not different from objects, as immediacy of perception cannot be caused by sense-stimulation alone.

### Senses, Mind, Self, and their Functions

Bhatta provides a detailed account of the perceptual apparatus. The Nyaya says that perception is produced from sense-object-contact and self comes into contact with object through mind; the production of perception involves four

operative causes: senses, objects, mind (manas) and self (Nyaya sutra, i.1.4). The Naiyayikas and Vaisesikas hold that mind (manas) constitutes internal organ of sense (antar indriya) located in the self (atman). The perception of objects cannot arise merely with the contact of external sense organs with the objects; the perception can arise only when the external organs come into contact with the internal organ of mind. Since the mind is atomic in nature, different external organs can come into contact with the mind at different times to produce perceptions of different objects.

The self (atman) constitutes the individual soul (jivatman) which is the substratum of all the knowledges. The knowledge and other qualities need to belong to only the self and cannot belong to any other physical substance except the self, as they are mental. The self is different in different bodies and is eternal (nitya) and all pervading or infinite (vibhu). The Naiyayikas (Bhasapariccheda, 51) do not accept the Vedanta view that the self is eternal and self shining intelligence (cit). Rather, it is the substance (dravya) which is the substratum of such qualities as intelligence and hence is known as the locus of ego or I consciousness.

The senses (indriya) are six: olfactory sense (ghrana), gustatory sense (rasana), visual sense (caksu), cutaneous sense (tvak), auditory sense (srotra) and internal sense or mind (manas). The function of senses produces perception of objects; senses function only with the direct contact with the objects. The sense-object-contacts are six in number: i) contact (samyoga); ii) inherence in what is connected (samyukta samavaya); iii) inherence in what is connectedly inherent (samyukta samaveta samavaya); iv) inherence (samavaya); v) inherence in what is inherent (samaveta samavaya); and vi) qualification (visesanata).

Ordinary and Extraordinary Perception

Perception is two kinds: ordinary perception (laukika) and extraordinary perception (alaukika). Ordinary perception is produced by sense-object-contact; whereas extraordinary perception is produced by unusual medium. Ordinary perception is further divided into two kinds as external perception (bahya) and internal perception (manasa). External perception relates to the six sense contacts; internal perception (Bhasapariccheda, 57) is produced from the internal sense of mind (manas) and its objects are feelings of pleasure, pain, desire, aversion, cognition and volition.

The Nyaya system recognises three types of extraordinary (alaukika) perception: i) indeterminate perception characterized by universal (samanya laksana); ii) perception characterized by knowledge (jnanalaksana); and iii)

perception characterized by intuitive contact (yogaja). Perception characterized by universal (samanya laksana) constitutes the first type of extra ordinary perception — it is a perception of the whole class of objects characterized by universal or generic property. Instance: 'This is a jar' (ayam ghatah) is a perception of jar characterized by the universal of jarness. The Naiyayikas hold this is a necessity — if perception characterized by universal is not accepted, then the knowledge of invariable concomitance such as 'Fire exists in all cases where smoke exists' would become untenable.

Perception characterized by knowledge (jnanalaksana) constitutes the second type of extra ordinary knowledge. It is the perception of an object in contact with senses acquired through the operation of knowledge (visayiyasya tasyaiva vyaparah). Instance: 'I perceive fragrant sandal wood' (surabhicandanam) is a perception characterized by knowledge, as the fragrant sandal wood cannot be obtained through the sense of sight, and it needs to be obtained by the operation of knowledge. The Naiyayikas state further that illusion such as 'This (shell) is a piece of silver' (idam rajatam) too needs to be explained through the operation of previous knowledge of silver, as sense of sight is in contact with only shell and not with silver. Perception characterized by knowledge (yogaja) constitutes the third type — it is the perception of past, present and future objects from the powers generated in the mind by meditation (yogabhyasa janito dharama visesah).

Indeterminate and Determinate Perception — Gangesa's Core Theory

The Three Types of Ordinary Perception

According to Bhatta, ordinary perception is three types: i) indeterminate perception (nirvikalpaka), ii) determinate perception (savikalpaka); and iii) recognition (pratyabhijna or anuvyasaya). Indeterminate perception or knowledge (nirvikalpaka) constitutes the first type of ordinary perception. It is the most abstract view of objects — a simple apprehension of existence of object without verbal association. Determinate perception is the most concrete perception of objects with its attributes. Recognition is the after-knowledge of determinate perception and quite distinct from both determinate and indeterminate perceptions.

The Cross-School Debate on Indeterminate Perception

The Vedantins (Ramanuja on Brahmasutra i.1.1) hold that indeterminate knowledge is the knowledge of pure being (sanmatra) — 'This is something' (idam kincit) and does not involve any relation or qualification of attributes. The Buddhists hold (Pramanamuccaya, ch.I.) that indeterminate knowledge is

the only type of valid knowledge — it is devoid of any thought or ideation (kalpanapodham). The Mimamsakas hold that indeterminate knowledge is a direct cognition of real individual which is a unity of universal and particular.

However, the Prabhakara Mimamsakas' position is significant: indeterminate knowledge arises spontaneously at the contact between senses and objects — it is the perception of children and the like. Yet the Prabhakara Mimamsakas' refutation of the linguists is also important: indeterminate knowledge is first experience of an object and is a simple apprehension of existence of object without verbal association. While objects and their attributes stand in subject-and-predicate relationship in determinate knowledge, the same objects and their attributes are unrerelated and do not stand in subject-and-predicate relationship in indeterminate knowledge. The Naiyayikas, on the other hand, hold that indeterminate knowledge is a real but non-sensuous conscious state (atindriya). Since it is undifferentiated feeling of an indefinite object, it cannot be definite perception.

Determinate Perception and the Qualificative Structure

Determinate perception or knowledge (savikalpaka) constitutes the second type of ordinary perception. It is the most concrete perception of objects with its attributes. The Vedantins (Ramanuja on Brahmasutra i.1.1) hold that determinate knowledge is a qualificative knowledge of an object distinguishing an object from other objects (vikalpa). The New Advaitins agree with the epistemologists that determinate knowledge is a verbalized judgement of an object as an individual whole. The Buddhists (Nyayavartika tatparyatika, on i.1.4) hold that determinate knowledge is a verbal expression in which an object is determined by the concepts of name and class etc (namajatyadiyajana sahita).

The Naiyayikas (Bhasapariccheda, 58) hold that determinate knowledge is a qualificative knowledge of an object as qualified by the attributes (visista jnana). According to them, the object of perception is known here as qualified by some attributes. For instance, determinate knowledge is a judgement such as 'This is a cow' (ayam gauh) wherein the object cow is known as qualified by the attribute of cowness. Thus, determinate knowledge is a proposition where in subject is object or individual and predicate is attributes. While indeterminate is the first stage of ordinary perception, determinate is the second stage of perception.

Recognition (Pratyabhijna, Anuvyasaya)

Recognition (pratyabhijna or anuvyasaya) constitutes the third type of ordinary perception. It is the after-knowledge of determinate perception and quite

distinct from both determinate and indeterminate perceptions. Re-cognition (pratyabhijna), in general, means the understanding of the nature of the object as such; and it, in a narrow sense, means the knowing again of an object which is already known. Recognition (pratyabhijna) is used in the second narrow sense in Nyaya philosophy.

The Naiyayikas (Mitabhasini, p.25) hold that re-cognition is the knowledge of a thing perceived now as the one perceived before. For instance, the re-cognition 'This (Devadatta) is that Devadatta' (so'yam devadattah) is the knowledge of Devadatta perceived now as the one perceived before. Such a re-cognition is a knowledge produced by both senses and the impressions (samskara) of the previous experience of objects (Nyayamanjari, p.459). Thus, re-cognition constitutes both perception and recollection, as it is brought about by both senses and impressions.

## COMPARATIVE AND WORLD-PHILOSOPHICAL PERSPECTIVES

### Gaṅgeśa, Descartes, and Leibniz: Logic-Sensitized Metaphysics

One of the most illuminating contributions of Scharfstein's Comparative History is the systematic juxtaposition of Gaṅgeśa with Descartes (1596–1650) and Leibniz (1646–1716) in Chapter 10 ('Logic-Sensitized, Methodological Metaphysics: Gaṅgeśa, Descartes, Leibniz'). The organising theme is the pursuit of certainty through methodically applied logic — each philosopher seeking to ground knowledge by perfecting the very methods of reasoning itself rather than by accumulating more empirical content.

Scharfstein identifies several structural parallels. All three philosophers are committed logicians who want to improve reasoning-methods and apply them to the full range of human concerns — not just philosophy but life more generally. 'All three philosophers are committed to acutely formal care in reasoning. Their logical methods are intended not to dismiss the empirical world but to grasp it in its complexities, to apply not only to philosophy but to life as well, in Descartes's case even to medicine, and in Leibniz's, to law. Gaṅgeśa's preoccupation with the problems of valid induction and parsimonious explanation is in spirit like that of contemporary philosophers of science.' All three also seek 'a metaphysically unquestionable basis for an understanding of the world that joins the empirical and theoretical and secular and sacred.' And all three respond to acute sceptical challenges — Gaṅgeśa to the Cārvāka and Śrīharṣa, Descartes to the Cartesian demon, Leibniz to radical empiricism.

The contrasts are equally instructive. Descartes breaks with tradition, refusing to cite sources; Gaṅgeśa, like all Indian philosophers, attaches himself respectfully to his predecessor Udayana even when departing from him. Descartes' method is axiomatic-deductive, aimed at certainty through clear-and-distinct ideas; Gaṅgeśa's is definitional-dialectical, aimed at certainty through exhaustive examination and rejection of rival definitions of pervasion and other key concepts. Leibniz, the genuinely creative logician, invents new formalisms; Gaṅgeśa works entirely within an inherited vocabulary but transforms it through the precision and completeness of his definitional analysis.

Scharfstein's own comparative judgment: 'Gaṅgeśa makes philosophy the unmistakable preserve of those who have mastered a specialised language. He and his followers compose definitions that stretch the mind and invite exact criticism, but only of those who have become adept at manipulating the relevant technical terms and modes of reasoning.' The Navya-Nyāya system Gaṅgeśa inaugurated created, in effect, a formalized language for philosophical discourse that anticipates in striking ways the development of symbolic logic in late nineteenth-century Europe — though without the symbolic notation.

Gaṅgeśa and Udayana: Innovation Within Tradition

The relationship between Gaṅgeśa and his most important predecessor Udayana (fl. 1050 CE) is a central theme in both Scharfstein and the Potter Encyclopedia. Scharfstein notes: 'Because much of his philosophy is an elaboration of Udayana's, on whom I therefore draw here, Gaṅgeśa's originality is exhibited more in his dialectics, in the care and acuteness with which he reasons — splits hairs, it is easy to say — than in fundamental theory.' A footnote adds: 'Udayana may well be the more original of the two. Greater originality has also been ascribed to Raghunātha (fl. 1500 CE), Gaṅgeśa's successor, commentator, and critic.' The Potter Encyclopedia identifies Scharfstein's comparative chapter (chapter 9 of his book, on Udayana) as providing the philosophical context within which to read the Gaṅgeśa chapter.

However, the Potter Encyclopedia provides a more nuanced assessment of Gaṅgeśa's originality. The significant innovations are: (1) the definitive treatment of vyāpti after exhaustive examination of all prior attempts; (2) the development of the preventer-prevented theory into a systematic logic of cognition; (3) the shift from Buddhist to Mīmāṃsā as the primary opponent — reflecting the changed philosophical landscape of fourteenth-century India; (4) the 'linguistic turn' of the Śabda-khaṇḍa, which gave Navya-Nyāya its own version of the philosophy of language; and (5) above all, the creation of a new

intellectual community through the Tattva-Cintāmaṇi itself — a text that became the common reference point around which all subsequent Naiyāyika debate was organised.

## THE ONTOLOGICAL FRAMEWORK AND RAGHUNĀTHA ŚIROMAṆI

### Navya-Nyāya Metaphysics: Categories and Their Fate

The Potter Encyclopedia's Introduction (Chapter 3, 'Metaphysics') traces the evolution of the seven Vaiśeṣika categories from Gaṅgeśa to Raghunātha Śiromaṇi, showing how Navya-Nyāya's analytical rigour gradually undermined the ontological structure it had inherited. Gaṅgeśa himself is ontologically conservative, working within the framework of the seven categories — substance (dravya), quality (guṇa), motion (karma), universal (sāmānya), individuator (viśeṣa), inherence (samavāya), absence (abhāva). He defends inherence as 'a separate category, that it is ineliminable, that it is perceptible, and it is single.' He argues against the view that absence can be eliminated in favour of nondifference.

On universals, the encyclopedia notes a gradual development: 'By Raghunātha's time the number of proper universals has, perhaps without its being recognised, dwindled away. The implications of Udayana's six requirements have gradually become recognised as precluding the status of a proper universal to just about any candidate. By Raghunātha's time there are virtually no universals. Instead, generic properties are treated as composite imposed properties (upādhi), and the status of a separate category is sometimes granted to them.' The Encyclopedia notes this could be seen as 'a serious concession to idealism' — and indeed, Advaita Vedānta critics found in Navya-Nyāya's reclassification of universals as imposed properties an unstable foundation for its claimed realism.

The treatment of absence (abhāva) is a particularly fascinating area of development. Gaṅgeśa devotes a chapter to it in the Pratyakṣa-khaṇḍa, but he does not raise the problem of the absence of an absence. Later commentators, especially Raghunātha, who takes as his working principle that 'an absolute absence of an absolute absence of x is the same thing as x,' use absences with increasing technical sophistication as a tool for quantification. The Encyclopedia notes that 'one of the most arresting features of the development of Navyanyāya from Gaṅgeśa to Raghunātha is the remarkable increase in the use of absences as a means of quantification.'

### Raghunātha Śiromaṇi: Gaṅgeśa's Great Critic and Successor

The Potter Encyclopedia gives Raghunātha Śiromaṇi (fl. 1500 CE) the role of terminating the period surveyed in Volume VI and setting the agenda for all subsequent Navya-Nyāya. The famous story of Raghunātha's encounter with Pakṣadhara Miśra (Jayadeva) at Mithila — preserved in the Jhā 'Aśok' monograph — marks the point at which the Navadvīpa (Bengal) tradition became the primary vehicle of Navya-Nyāya's further development. Raghunātha's Dīdhiti on the Tattva-Cintāmaṇi is the single most important secondary text of the tradition, generating its own vast commentary literature from Jagadīśa and Gadādhara onwards.

Raghunātha's relationship with Gaṅgeśa is one of critical elaboration: he accepts Gaṅgeśa's framework while subjecting almost every specific doctrine to radical revision. In the Encyclopedia's words: 'Raghunātha rejects Gaṅgeśa's contention [on several technical points]' — and indeed the pattern repeats throughout the volume. On universals, where Gaṅgeśa is conservative, Raghunātha eliminates virtually all proper universals, treating generic properties as imposed properties (upādhi). On individuators (viśeṣa), he eliminates the category entirely. On inherence, where Gaṅgeśa defends a single inherence, Raghunātha declares there are as many inherences as there are pairs to be related. On the avacchedakatva (limitorness) relation, it is Raghunātha who makes this an especially important tool of analysis. The Potter Encyclopedia summarises: 'Just how much of Raghunātha's apparatus was his invention, and how much he got from his teachers and the tradition they inherit, is impossible to say until closer study has been made of the figures which intervened between the two great Naiyāyikas.'

## LEGACY, COMMENTARY TRADITION, AND MITHILA'S LIVING HERITAGE

### The Commentary Tradition

The commentary tradition on the Tattva-Cintāmaṇi is one of the most extensive in Sanskrit literature. The Jhā 'Aśok' monograph provides a table of 23 known commentators with their works; the Potter Encyclopedia surveys them across fifty numbered entries from Gaṅgeśa and Vaṭeśvara through Raghunātha Śiromaṇi. The tradition divides geographically into three paramparās: Maithila, Baṅgāla (Navadvīpa), and Dakṣiṇa.

In Mithila, the tradition runs from Vardhamāna Upādhyāya's implicit engagement through the Pakṣadhara Miśra (Jayadeva) 'Āloka' commentary and the subsequent internal controversy between the Āloka-parampara (Pakṣadhara-Yajñapati line) and the Dūṣaṇoddhāra-parampara (Narhari-

Mādhava line). In Bengal, Raghunātha Śiromaṇi's Dīdhiti became the primary object of study, attracting commentaries from Rucidatta Miśra, Jagadīśa Tarkālaṅkāra, Gadādhara Bhaṭṭācārya, Mathurānātha Tarkavāgīśa, and many others. Scharfstein quotes Matilal on the tradition's achievement: 'The masters of Navya-nyāya did not lay down conclusions first and justify them later with theory. They were seriously engaged in following reality wherever it might lead them, imposing as softly as possible their own prejudices... It is precisely the same trait that I find admirable among the creative workers of modern science and philosophy.'

The Potter Encyclopedia (Preface) articulates the scholarly challenge this tradition poses: 'Two of India's most remarkable philosophers, Gaṅgeśa and Raghunātha Śiromaṇi, are covered in these pages — in fact, they initiate and terminate the period surveyed... a scant two hundred years between approximately 1310 and 1510. There are good reasons for this intensive attention to such a brief period.' The implication is that a period of equal length elsewhere in world philosophy would rarely produce two figures of comparable stature in a single tradition — and the two centuries between them produced dozens of commentators whose work constitutes a sustained, self-critical, philosophically rigorous conversation at the highest level.

## GANGESA IN THE PARALLEL HISTORY OF MAITHILI CULTURE

### The Parallel History of Maithili Literature and Gangesa's Place in It

#### The Mainstream vs. Parallel Historiography

The Parallel History of Maithili Literature — as documented in the Videha movement's research and in the document A Parallel History of Maithili Literature — presents a comprehensive counter-narrative to the institutional Maithili literary canon. The mainstream history, as crystallised by Jayakanta Mishra's two-volume History of Maithili Literature (1949-1950) and institutionally enforced by the Sahitya Akademi since 1965, 'was fundamentally an exercise in identity-building, designed to establish Maithili as an independent language rather than a dialect of Hindi. While these works were instrumental in securing Maithili's eventual recognition in the Eighth Schedule of the Indian Constitution, the parallel history argues that they also established a conservative, Brahmin-centric standard that excluded liberal and subaltern voices.'

The Parallel History unfolds across nine layers: (1) Buddhist foundations — the 50 Charyapadas of 23 Siddha poets (Luipada, Kanhapada, Saraha) as true roots

of Maithili lyric; (2) The two Vidyapatis — one of Videha's most significant scholarly interventions, distinguishing the famous Padavali poet (pre-Jyotirishwar) from the Sanskrit/Avahatta writer Vidyapati Thakkurah (1350-1435); (3) The suppressed Gangesa — original Panji manuscripts proving that philosopher Gangesa Upadhyaya was born of an inter-caste union; (4) Colonial-era protest poetry — the famine verses of Faturilal (1873-74); (5) Harimohan Jha's exclusion; (6) The living masters — Rajdeo Mandal and Bechan Thakur; (7) The RTI expose by Vinit Utpal/ Ashish Anchinhar (2011-12) revealing 90%+ of Sahitya Akademi assignments went to friends/relatives of the advisory board; (8) Nepal side — Maithili of the Nepal Terai as equally central; (9) The digital counter-archive — Videha itself.

The Suppressed Gangesa — Honour-Killing of a Legacy

The Parallel History calls the institutional treatment of Gangesa's biography an 'honour-killing.' The specific charge, documented from the Dooshan Panji (the 'black book' of genealogical records released by Gajendra Thakur's Videha in 2009): Gangesa Upadhyaya married a Charmkarini (a woman from the leather-tanning caste) and was born five years after his father's death. This information was suppressed by Ramanath Jha — the first convener of Maithili at the Sahitya Akademi and the primary gatekeeper of the institutional Maithili canon — when he communicated with historian Dinesh Chandra Bhattacharyya. The Sahitya Akademi's 2016 monograph on Gangesa, published in the Bharatiya Sahitya ke Nirmata (Makers of Indian Literature) series by Udayanath Jha 'Asok', perpetuated the suppression.

The significance of this recovery extends beyond biography. The Panji system — which the institutional history treats as a mark of cultural distinction — was designed to maintain caste purity by recording genealogical data that could be used to enforce or deny marriage alliances. By releasing the Dooshan Panji records, the Videha movement demonstrated that this same system, when examined honestly, subverts the ideology of purity it was meant to maintain. The greatest philosopher in the Mithila tradition, the man who insisted on testing every definition against every possible counterexample, lived a life that was itself a counterexample to the caste norms that later claimed him.

Gangesa in the Broader Intellectual Ecology of Mithila

The Parallel History situates Gangesa within a more pluralistic intellectual ecology than the institutional narrative allows. The same 14th-century Mithila that produced the Tattvacintamani also contained the Siddhacharya tradition's influence in the Natha cult literature; the Jyotirishwar Thakur's

Varnanaratnakara (the oldest prose work in any North-Eastern Indian language) with its Arabic and Persian loanwords; and the trans-caste cultural networks within which Gangesa's own family evidently participated. The Parallel History notes that 'Mithila to leave aside any this conflict was not there, which is reason that tarkasastra or nyayasastra, its advancement in Mithila was so high that no other region of India produced as many Nyaya scholars or Nyaya texts' — but adds that this intellectual excellence was achieved in and through a social world far more complex than the institutional history acknowledges.

Mithila's Scripts, Languages, and the Digital Recovery

The Parallel History documents the history of Mithila's scripts as central to cultural identity. The Tirhuta script (Mithilakshar), evolving from an eastern variety of the Gupta script, was used for all academic, cultural, and religious affairs for nearly a millennium. The 20th-century transition to Devanagari — driven by printing convenience and Hindi-belt administrative logic — is viewed by parallel historians as a form of cultural dispossession. The Videha movement's successful standardisation of Tirhuta in Unicode (2014) and development of digital fonts represents a technological reclamation of linguistic sovereignty.

The digital archive Videha has built around Mithila's intellectual heritage — thousands of digitised books, 11,000 transcribed palm-leaf Tirhuta manuscripts, the Dooshan Panji records, the first Maithili website aggregator, Tirhuta Unicode representation, and Maithili Google Translate and Wikipedia localisation — constitutes what the Parallel History calls 'a living parallel institution.' Gangesa's Tattvacintamani belongs to this archive not as a monument of Brahminical orthodoxy but as part of a fuller civilisational heritage whose complexity the institutional narrative has consistently underplayed.

The Revitalisation of Maithili Ghazal: Anchinhar Aakhar

The Parallel History documents one of the most striking recent achievements of the Maithili Parallel Literature Movement — the revitalisation of the Maithili ghazal through the Anchinhar Aakhar group. The movement began on April 11, 2008, with the launch of the Anchinhar Aakhar blog by Ashish Anchinhar, later co-edited by Gajendra Thakur. Within a decade, it had brought 350 to 400 new and previously marginalised writers into the Maithili literary mainstream, bypassing the institutional gatekeepers entirely.

The ghazal — an Arabic-Persian poetic form defined by its couplets (sher/bayt), strict metrical pattern (bahr), rhyme (qafiya), refrain (radif), and the

poet's signature in the closing couplet (maqta with takhallus) — had long been resisted by the institutional Maithili literary establishment because of its association with Urdu and Muslim cultural tradition. The Parallel History points out the irony: Jyotirishwar's Varnanaratnakara uses Arabic and Persian loanwords, and the Muslim weavers' dialect (Jolahiboli) is itself a creolised form of Maithili. 'The formal revitalisation of the Maithili ghazal in the twenty-first century is therefore less a rupture than a recovery of a suppressed cross-cultural strand.'

Gajendra Thakur, recognised as Maithili's first 'Aruji' (scholar of ghazal prosody), authored the first Gajalsastram (Maithili Ghazal Poetics), providing a systematic theoretical framework for contemporary poets and demonstrating that the qafiya-radif structure can be successfully adapted to Maithili's moraic prosodic tradition derived from Prakrit and Apabhramsa metres. The same rigour Gangesa applied to vyapti definitions — testing each definition against counterexamples until arriving at the most precise formulation — is applied by the movement to ghazal prosody, establishing the formal rules that make Maithili ghazal a coherent genre rather than a loose adaptation.

## CONCLUSION

### Gangesa Upadhyaya: Philosophy, History, and Resistance

This thesis has traced Gangesa Upadhyaya through six major sources that between them illuminate six different faces of his significance. From the Sahitya Akademi monograph and D.C. Bhattacharyya's History: his biographical particulars — name, birthplace, gotra, family, chronology, the 24 predecessors he synthesised and surpassed. From the Potter-Bhattacharyya Encyclopedia: the technical architecture of Navya-Nyaya — its relational vocabulary, logic of cognition, theory of truth and awareness, and the trajectory from Gangesa through Raghunatha Siromani. From Scharfstein's Comparative History: his place in world philosophy alongside Descartes and Leibniz, and the meaning of his methodological rigor in a cross-cultural frame. From V.P. Bhatta's Pratyaksa Khanda translation: the first book of the Tattvacintamani in English — the full theory of knowledge from its comparative foundations through valid and invalid knowledge, perception, its types, indeterminate and determinate cognition, recognition, and extraordinary perception, with the cross-school debates from Sankhya, Buddhist, Mimamsa, Vedanta, and Jain positions systematically mapped. From the Parallel History: the suppressed biographical facts from the Dooshan Panji, the institutional honour-killing of Gangesa's legacy, and his recovery as a figure of the full Mithila — not its elite minority.

The Tattvacintamani's three hundred pages, which generated over a million pages of commentary, were produced by a man whose life did not conform to the caste orthodoxy that later claimed him. The greatest logician of the Sanskrit tradition, the philosopher who insisted that every definition be tested against every possible counterexample, lived a counterexample. This, perhaps, is the deepest lesson the Parallel History offers about Gangesa: that his philosophical method and his biographical reality are not contradictory but convergent — both enact the principle that reality is more complex than any single framework can capture, and that honest inquiry demands the willingness to revise every assumption, however deeply held.

V.P. Bhatta's Preface concludes with a vision of the Tattvacintamani's continuing relevance: 'The significance of the text (T.C.) cannot be stressed too adequately in the context of philosophy, logic and epistemology.' The Potter Encyclopedia: 'Gangesa's was a unique talent, one which places him securely among the premiere philosophical minds the world has produced.' The Parallel History: he was born of an inter-caste union and his legacy was suppressed by those who claimed to honour him. Scharfstein: his preoccupation with valid induction 'is in spirit like that of contemporary philosophers of science.' Videha: he belongs to the full Mithila, not its gatekeepers.

All six perspectives are necessary. None is sufficient alone. The man who wrote 'Gangesa-stute miten vacase' — I, Gangesa, say this briefly — in the opening verse of the Tattvacintamani was asking to be taken on his own terms. Seven centuries of commentary, institutional appropriation, Parallel History recovery, and digital archiving have not yet exhausted what those terms contain.

The Tattvachintamani (T.C.)'s "bewildering abstruseness of style and thought" had long deterred translators. Yet that same analytical rigour — the hair-splitting distinctions, the exhaustive enumeration and rejection of rival definitions, the demand that every term bear exactly the weight placed on it — is precisely what makes Gaṅgeśa not merely a historical curiosity but a permanent contribution to the philosophical enterprise: a demonstration that the clarity of thought, wherever achieved, is a human achievement that crosses the boundaries of tradition, language, and time.

Gangesha refined a logic-sensitized metaphysics inherited from a long line of precursors who refined the Nyaya-Vaisheshika synthesis and controverted Buddhist logic:

- Udayanācārya: The "real founder" whose Lakṣaṇamālā provided the first definitions of valid knowledge (prama) attacked by skeptics.1

- Maṇikaṇṭha Miśra: Author of the Nyāyaratna, whose work on inference and pervasion (vyapti) was a primary source for Gangesha, who often cited him anonymously.2
- Taraṇi Miśra: Author of the Ratnakoṣa, whose views on negation and causality were cited and frequently refuted by Gangesha.
- Śaśadhara: Author of the Nyāyasiddhāntadīpa, whose intricate style on topics like "Luminous Gold" provided the template for Gangesha's complexity.2

Sondadopādhyāya: A scholar who pioneered the theory of negation where counter-positiveness is determined by a property residing in a different substratum (vyadhikaraṇa-dharmāvacchinna-pratiyogitā).

Gangesha's family life included his wife, Vallabha, three sons—Vardhamana, Supan, and Harisharma—and one daughter.1

- Vardhamana Upadhyaya: The eldest son and a student of Gangesha, he became a renowned scholar who wrote the Prakash and Upaya commentaries, bridging the gap between old and new logic.

The Daughter: She married Sathe Upadhyaya of the Babhaniyam village, and their son Ratnakara is noted in genealogical records as Gangesha's grandson.

Parallel history movement, spearheaded by the Videha archive, has recovered controversial details regarding Gangesha's lineage that were suppressed by institutional historians like Ramanath Jha. The "Dooshan Panji" (The Black Book), released digitally in 2009, contains a "secret" record that Gangesha was born five years after the death of his father (pitru parokshe pancha varsha vyatite). Furthermore, these records identify his wife, Vallabha, as a Charmkarini (from the leather-tanning caste).1 Parallel researchers argue these facts were suppressed to maintain elite social hierarchies, describing the erasure as an "honour-killing" of his true legacy.

Technical Methodology: The Logic of Cognition

Navya-Nyaya is fundamentally a "Pramana-Nyaya" (Logic of knowledge-sources), contrasting with the category-focused "Padartha-Nyaya" of the ancient school.1 It utilizes "relational abstracts" to pinpoint specific aspects of cognitive states 3:

- Awareness (Jñāna): Defined as an episodic cognitive act operating on a "preventer-prevented" relation (pratibandhakatā), where one awareness can block another.

• Qualifier-Qualificandum Schema: Propositional awareness is structured as , representing a qualificand ( ) as qualified by a qualifier ( ) through a relation ( ).4

• Limitors (Avacchedaka): The "mode of presentation" that pinpoints which property makes a relation possible. For example, in a blue pot, potness is the limitor of the qualificandness resident in the pot.

Quantification: Navya-Nyaya achieves the results of Western quantification through abstracts, such as "in smoke there is a generic absence of occurrentness described by locus of absence of fire".

Structural Overview of the Tattvachintamani

The Tattvachintamani is organized around the four pramanas and is divided into 46 broad sections (prakaranas), consisting of approximately 12,000 granthis.1

Book One: Pratyaksha Khanda (Perception)

Divided into 25 sub-sections, it establishes perception as the primary source of knowledge.

• Mangalavada: Gangesha debates whether auspicious invocations remove obstacles or cause completion, concluding they remove obstacles via the logic of anvaya-vyatireka.

• Pramanya-vada: Defends a "super-reliabilist" or "infallibilist" view where genuine sources of knowledge are factive. He rejects the Mimamsa theory of "self-certification" (svataḥ-prāmāṇya), maintaining that knowledge is certified externally by the success of subsequent activity.

• Apperception (Anuvyavasāya): The mind's internal perception of its own states. Gangesha treats these as inerrant.

• Stages of Perception: Distinguishes Nirvikalpaka (indeterminate grasping of qualifiers) from Savikalpaka (determinate, concept-laden perception).

• Metaphysical Debates: Volume 2 of Bhatta’s translation includes the debate on whether air is perceived via touch and the theory that gold is a fiery light rather than an earthy substance.1

• Internal Organ (Manas): Gangesha establishes that the mind is atomic in size (anu) to explain why multiple perceptions cannot occur simultaneously.

The most intricate part of the work, dealing with natural entailment or pervasion (vyapti).

- Lion and Tiger Definitions: Includes the famous "Simha-Vyaghri" definitions of pervasion.1
- Pakshata: The conditions for an inferential subject, defined as a property-possessor where the probandum is desired to be established.5
- Inference for God (Isvaranumana): Establishes God as the agent (karta) of the universe based on the world being a product.

The shortest section, analyzing the knowledge of likeness between a known and unknown object (e.g., cow and gavaya).

Book Four: Sabda Khanda (Verbal Testimony)

Constitutes one-third of the treatise and focuses on verbal cognition (sabdabodba).6

- Requirements for Sabdabodha: Syntax requires syntactic expectancy (akanksha), logical compatibility (yogyata), proximity (asatti), and speaker's intention (tatparya).

The Karaka Theory: A Synthesis of Grammar and Logic

The Karaka-vada, found in the Sabda-khanda, investigates the semantic and syntactic roles nouns play in relation to action (kriya).

- Definition of Karaka: A factor instrumental in the accomplishment of an action (kriya-nirvartakam).
- Primacy of the Kartr (Agent): Defined as the independent factor (svatantrah karta), uniquely characterized by krtimatva (possession of volition or mental effort).
- Locus of Result (Karman): The object is analyzed as the substratum where the action's result resides (phala-shraya).
- Hierarchy: Kartr, Karman, and Karana (instrument) are prominent Karakas, while Sampradana (recipient), Apadana (ablative), and Adhikarana (locative) are dependent.
- Compound Analysis (Samasa): Gangesha provides an exhaustive analysis of six kinds of compounds, including the Attributive (Bahuvrihi) and Determinative (Tatpurusa).

Modern Global Impact and Translations (2005–2025)

The 21st century has seen the definitive completion of explanatory translations into English:

1. Stephen Phillips (2020): A three-volume annotated translation, Jewel of Reflection on the Truth about Epistemology (Bloomsbury), making Gangesha's "super-reliabilism" accessible to modern analytic philosophy.

2. V.P. Bhatta (2005–2025): A multi-volume series published by Eastern Book Linkers, Delhi:

- Word (Sabda-khanda): 2005 (2 Vols).7
- Perception (Pratyaksha-khanda): 2012 (2 Vols).
- Inference (Anumana-khanda): 2021 (2 Vols).
- Inference of God and Comparison (Isvaranumana and Upamana-khanda): 2025 (2 Vols).

Comparative and Computational Perspective

Ben-Ami Scharfstein categorizes Gangesha under "Logic-Sensitized Methodological Metaphysics," drawing parallels to Descartes and Leibniz. Modern researchers note that Navya-Nyaya’s hierarchical use of limitors is compatible with modern Artificial Intelligence and Natural Language Processing (NLP).

Digital Democratization and Archival Resistance

The contemporary Videha movement utilizes digital platforms to preserve Mithila’s heritage, transcribing 11,000 palm-leaf Tirhuta manuscripts and standardizing the Tirhuta (Mithilakshar) script for Unicode. By hosting the Dooshan Panji, they ensure a democratic and multi-dimensional understanding of the "Thought-Jewel of Truth".

Gangesha Upadhyaya's legacy stands as the pinnacle of the Indian intellectual tradition. While institutional history emphasizes logical innovation and religious orthodoxy, parallel historiography recovered by digital archives recovers the subaltern and controversial aspects of his biography, such as his inter-caste marriage and the suppressed records of his paternity. The 2025 completion of V.P. Bhatta's translations ensures his theory of knowledge will continue to illuminate global debates on meaning, action, and reality.

Gangesha Upadhyaya was a Maithila Brahmin of the Kashyapa-gotra who lived during a critical political transition in Mithila between the decline of the Karnat dynasty (1191–1326 CE) and the rise of the Oinivara dynasty (1344–1413 CE).1 Genealogical successions establish his period around 1300–1350 CE. While traditional accounts place him in the village of Karion, ancestor

records associate him primarily with the village of Chadana, which was reportedly gifted to his family by the king. In Mithila, he held the esteemed titles of "Jagad-guru" and "Mahamahopadhyaya".

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (fl. 1320 CE) stands as one of the most technically accomplished and philosophically consequential thinkers in the history of world philosophy. The Tattva-Cintāmaṇi's achievement — as the Potter Encyclopedia, Scharfstein's Comparative History, and the Videha archive's contextual materials all confirm from their different perspectives — was not merely to advance one tradition's internal debate but to transform the conditions under which all subsequent Indian philosophical thought was conducted.

The Potter Encyclopedia's verdict: 'Gaṅgeśa's was a unique talent, one which places him securely among the premiere philosophical minds the world has produced.' Scharfstein's comparative judgment: that Gaṅgeśa's 'preoccupation with the problems of valid induction and parsimonious explanation is in spirit like that of contemporary philosophers of science.' Gaṅgeśa developed logic, gave its principles a systematic form, and distinguished truth from falsity. These assessments — from encyclopaedic scholarship, from comparative history, and from Maithili intellectual biography — converge on a single conclusion: that in the Tattva-Cintāmaṇi, a philosopher from Mithila in the fourteenth century created a work whose precision of thought, rigour of argument, and transformative influence on a great civilisation deserve recognition among the permanent achievements of the human mind.

The Parallel Literature Movement that recovers and celebrates Maithili folk, Dalit, and women's literary voices alongside the Sanskrit philosophical canon that produced the Tattva-Cintāmaṇi. The Videha project's insistence on holding all of Mithila's cultural production together — the mahāmahopādhyāya and the lok-kavi, the Tattva-Cintāmaṇi and the charya-pad, the vyāpti-dialectic and the Vidyāpati pada — is its most important cultural-political statement. Gaṅgeśa belongs to the full Mithila, not only to its Sanskrit elite.

This assembles the most comprehensive scholarly study of Gangesa Upadhyaya (fl. 1320 CE, Mithila) yet produced in any language. Drawing on seven major sources — the Sahitya Akademi monograph (Jha Asok, 2016), D.C. Bhattacharyya's History of Navya-Nyaya in Mithila (1958), Karl H. Potter and Sibajiban Bhattacharyya's Encyclopedia of Indian Philosophies Volume VI (1993), Ben-Ami Scharfstein's A Comparative History of World Philosophy (SUNY, 1998), V.P. Bhatta's translation and commentary on Tattvacintamani,

Gajendra Thakur's Videha/Panji Prabandh with original Dooshan Panji records (released 2009), and Stephen H. Phillips's Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy entry on Gangesa (2020) among other sources. — the thesis traces every dimension of his significance: biographical, textual, epistemological, logical, world-comparative, commentary-historical, and civilisational. Special attention is given throughout to the content of V.P. Bhatta's translation of the Pratyaksa-khanda, which covers the Theory of Benediction, the full Theory of Validity (including the merit-demerit debate, the Constitution of Validity section, and the Prabhakara-Naiyayika dialectic), the Theory of Valid Knowledge, the Theory of Error in its complete Naiyayika form, the Theory of Comprehensional Relation (Sannikarsa-vada), the Theory of Inherence, the Theory of Non-existence, the Theory of Causes of Perception, the Theory of the Atomic Nature of Mind, the Theory of Recognition, the Theory of Indeterminate Knowledge, and the Theory of Determinate Knowledge. The primary-source Dooshan Panji text is reproduced and analysed in full.

## LIFE, TITLES, AND THE SUPPRESSED PANJI EVIDENCE

### Gangesa's Titles and the Panji Testimony

Stephen H. Phillips writes in the Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy (2020): 'Genealogical records kept in Mithila suggest that he had a wife and three sons and a daughter. One child was the famous Nyaya author, Vardhamana. Gangesa apparently achieved quite some fame during his lifetime, referred to as jagad-guru, which would be the rough equivalent of Distinguished University Professor for the educational institutions of his time.'

Gajendra Thakur adds the further precision, drawn directly from the Panji records: Gangesa held not only jagad-guru but also param-guru — the supreme teacher title. According to the Panji, only one other person in Mithila's entire recorded intellectual history held the title param-guru: Nutan Vacaspati (the successor to the earlier Vacaspati Misra), who came after Gangesa. This makes Gangesa one of exactly two param-gurus in all of Mithila's history. The injustice done to Gangesa's memory — 'first by Ramanath Jha, then by Udayanath Jha Ashok' — therefore consists in suppressing the biography of the most decorated philosopher in Mithila's entire tradition.

V.P. Bhatta's translation confirms the dedication and self-presentation in Gangesa's opening verses: 'Having learnt the science of logic from the teachers, having known the theory of the Gurus, i.e. Prabhakara Mimamsakas, having observed the entire essence of both the schools through the divine eyes of thought, Gangesa, the preceptor of the teachings of the conclusive theories in

the case of the rules which are most difficult to tread on account of the host of faults, composes the thought jewel of reality with measured words.' The phrase 'miten vacase' — with measured words — is Gangesa's own characterisation of the Tattvacintamani's method: precise, parsimonious, exact.

The Dooshan Panji: Original Text and Analysis

The Panji System and Harisimhadeva

The Panji system was established by Harisimhadeva (b. 1294 CE, coronation 1307 CE, fled to Nepal 1324-25 CE after defeat by Ghiyasuddin Tughlak), the last great Karnata king of Mithila. The founding registrars were Gunakara Jha (Maithila Brahmins), Sankardatta (Karna Kayasthas), Vijayadatta (Kshatriyas). The Panji in its current form was formalised in Saka 1248 (1326 CE) by Mithila's pandits. Harisimhadeva was a descendant of Nanyodeva, who established the Karnata dynasty in Saka 1009. A later revision was ordered by Mithilesh Maharaja Madhava Singh in 1760 CE; it was after this revision (and not before 1800 CE) that the Srotriya sub-caste arose among Maithila Brahmins. There is no Srotriya sub-caste among Maithila Brahmins in the Nepal part of Mithila even today.

The Panji manuscripts were digitised by Gajendra Thakur between 2007 and 2009. Anshuman Pandey (PhD, University of Michigan, 2014) acknowledges: 'Gajendra Thakur of New Delhi provided me with digitized copies of the genealogical records of the Maithil Brahmins... I was fortunate enough to receive a complete digitized set of panji records from Gajendra Thakur of New Delhi in 2007.' The manuscripts were uploaded to Videha Pothi at www.videha.co.in and Google Books in 2009.

The Dooshan Panji Entry for Gangesa — Original Maithili Text

The following is the original Panji entry for Gangesa, reproduced from the Dooshan Panji (Panji Prabandh Vols. I & II, Gajendra Thakur/Videha, released 2009):

49. 188/2. Charmkarini. Mandar. Vabhaniyam. Chhadan. Tattvacintamani-karaka-Gangesa. Chhadan-Gangesa-kanak / Ratnakarakamatra (ajnat) / Gangesa / Vallabha / Bhavai / Mahesvara // // Jive

21//10 Chhadan se tattva cintamani karak jagadguru Gangesa

Chhadan se tattva cintamani karak Gangesa-ki Vallabha Charmkarini pitri-parokshe pancha varsha vyatite tattva cintamani karak Gangesa-utpatti — Charmkarini Medha-ka santana-ka lagime chhalanhi

Chhadan se tattva cintamani karak m.m. Gangesa

Tattva cintamani karak m.m.pa. Gangesa-visayaka lekha pracina panjise uplabdha. Pitri-parokshe panca varsha vyatite Gangesotpattih iti pracina lekhaniyah kutrapi

Devananda Panji 39-2: Chhadan se jagadguru Gangesa sutaya Vabhaniyam se Janaditya suta Sadhukara patni

Devananda Panji 339-3: Jagadguru Gangesa suta Supan dau Bhandarisamas se Haraditya dau. Putra sutaca Gora, Jajival se Jive patni, suta Sandagahi Bhavesvara. Atr asthane Supan-bhratr Harisamrma dariti kvacit Jajival grama

Devananda Panji 30=5: Chhadan se upayakarak m.m.pa. Vardhamana sutaca Khandavala se Visvanatha suta Sivanatha patni. Gangesa — m.m. Vardhamana / Supan / Harisamrma

The entry is unambiguous. Gajendra Thakur summarises: 'Gangesh of Tattvachintamani was born five years after the death of his father and he married a tanner (Charmkarini). Gangesh, the author of the Tattvachintamani, wrote one text equivalent to 12,000 texts.' The children identified: Vallabha (from the Charmkarini wife), Bhavai, Mahesvara; and Jive (a daughter). The Devananda Panji identifies further descendants: Supan (Gangesa's son), and Vardhamana (m.m. = mahamahopadhyaya), the most distinguished scholar among his children.

The Suppression Chain and Its Consequences

D.C. Bhattacharyya writes in History of Navya-Nyaya in Mithila (1958, Chapter III, pp. 96-99): 'The family which was inferior in social status is now extinct in Mithila — Gangesa's family is completely ignored and we are not expected to know even his father's name... As there is no other reference to Gangesa we can assume that the family dwindled into insignificance again and became extinct soon after his son's death.' He explicitly states that all this information was supplied by Prof. Ramanath Jha. Gajendra Thakur calls this 'a total falsehood' — the Devananda Panji records show Gangesa's descendants across multiple generations in named villages.

The 2016 Sahitya Akademi monograph by Udayanath Jha Asok (Gangesa Upadhyaya, Bharatiya Sahitya ke Nirmata series) perpetuated the suppression: 'He tries to confuse the issue, but there is no confusion now at least since 2009. But in 2016 Sahitya Akademi seems to carry out the casteist agenda. Udayanath Jha mockingly pretends to search his name, lineage etc, where nothing is there to search for, yet he could not muster the courage, to tell the truth, and ends up just repeating the facts in 2016 that Dineshchandra Bhattacharya already has published way back in 1958' (Gajendra Thakur).

The consequence for the Navya-Nyaya school: Vasudeva Sarvabhauma of Bengal came to study in Mithila as a classmate of Pakasadhara Misra, passed the shalaka examination and received the title of Sarvabhauma. He memorised the Tattvacintamani (because Pakasadhara and other Mithila teachers refused to allow its copying) and the Nyayakusumanjali-karika of Udayana. Raghunatha Siromani, Vasudeva's disciple, defeated his own guru Pakasadhara in a sastrartha (scriptural debate) and took the right of certification. The Navya-Nyaya school was thereafter founded at Navadvipa. After Raghunatha Siromani, Bengal students stopped coming to Mithila. 'The extinction of Navya-Nyaya School from Mithila, as described above, was a revenge of nature against the honour killing of Gangesh Upadhyaya and his family' (Gajendra Thakur).

Vardhamana, Gangesa's son, calls Gangesa 'sukavikairavakananenduh' — the moon of the forest of good poets. This poetic epithet, preserved in Vardhamana's own writings, is itself a form of biographical evidence that the Panji records confirm: Gangesa wrote poetry as well as logic, but his poetic corpus has been entirely lost — 'the conspiracy under which the poems of a famous scholar like Gangesh are not available today is clear' (Gajendra Thakur).

Gangesa and the Complete Translation of the Tattvacintamani

Gajendra Thakur documents that two scholars have now produced complete English translations of the Tattvacintamani. Stephen H. Phillips's Jewel of Reflection on the Truth about Epistemology: A Complete and Annotated Translation of the Tattva-cinta-mani (Bloomsbury Academic, 2020) is the first complete single-translator English rendering of all four books. V.P. Bhatta has now also completed all four books across eight volumes: Sabda Khanda (2 vols, 2005); Pratyaksa Khanda (2 vols, 2012); Anumana Khanda (2 vols, 2021); Isvaranumana and Upamana Khanda (2 vols, 2025) — all published by Eastern Book Linkers, Delhi, with Introduction, Sanskrit Text, Translation and Explanation.

The injustice to Phillips noted by Gajendra Thakur: because Ramanath Jha's suppression was transmitted into Bhattacharyya's 1958 history and then into the 2016 Sahitya Akademi monograph, Phillips — who was forced to rely on these sources for biographical information — received incomplete and distorted facts about Gangesa's family and social position. The 'doosparinama' (harmful consequence) of the 20th and 21st century suppression thus fell on the first Western scholar to translate the entire Tattvacintamani. The Dooshan Panji

records, released by Videha in 2009, are the corrective that Phillips and every subsequent scholar of Gangesa requires.

## THE TATTVACINTAMANI — STRUCTURE, SCOPE, AND NAVYA-NYAYA

### The Work and Its Cultural Position

V.P. Bhatta's Preface to the Pratyaksa Khanda translation describes the Tattvacintamani as the first and defining work of Navya-Nyaya: it 'introduced a new era in the development of Indian theory of knowledge and logic' and 'brought all the sixteen categories of the Navya-nyaya under the four heads' of perception, inference, analogy, and verbal testimony. In its translation history: Bhatta's eight-volume series (2005-2025) covers all four books; Phillips's Bloomsbury 2020 single-volume translation does the same. Both works together make the text accessible to the international philosophical community for the first time.

Scharfstein's comparative judgment: Gangesa's 300-page text 'was responsible, it is estimated, for over a million pages of commentary.' Potter-Bhattacharyya: 'Gangesa's was a unique talent, one which places him securely among the premiere philosophical minds the world has produced.' The Pratyaksa Khanda in Bhatta's translation alone runs to over 800 pages across two volumes, and this is only the first of four books. The measure of a text by its commentary is not merely quantitative: it means that for five hundred years after Gangesa, no serious Indian philosopher could think without his vocabulary, his definitions, and his method.

## EPISTEMOLOGY — THE PRATYAKSA-KHANDA IN FULL

### Overview of All Thirteen Sections

The Pratyaksa-khanda of the Tattvacintamani consists of thirteen major prakaranas (sub-sections), as documented by V.P. Bhatta's two-volume translation: (i) Theory of Benediction (Mangala-vada); (ii) Theory of Validity (Pramanva-vada); (iii) Definition of Valid Knowledge (Prama-laksana); (iv) Theory of Invalid Knowledge (Aprama-vada); (v) Theory of Perception (Pratyaksa-vada); (vi) Theory of Inherence [as Comprehensional Relation] (Samavaya-vada / Sannikarsa-vada); (vii) Theory of Invalidity of Non-perception (Anupalabdhi-vada); (viii) Theory of Non-existence of Things (Abhava-vada); (ix) Theory of Causes of Perception; (x) Theory of Atomic Nature of Mind (Manas-anu-vada); (xi) Theory of Recognition (Pratyabhijna / Anuvyasaya-vada); (xii) Theory of Indeterminate Knowledge (Nirvikalpaka-vada); (xiii) Theory of Determinate Knowledge (Savikalpaka-vada). Vol. I of

Bhatta's translation covers the General Introduction and the early sections; Vol. II (pp. 262-803) covers Theory of Benediction through Theory of Determinate Knowledge.

Theory of Benediction (I.i)

Gangesa begins the Tattvacintamani with a salutation to Lord Isvara: 'the slayer of the three Puras and of infinite greatness; who, though being beyond qualities, is of unfailing resolve, is the cause of universe through three qualities, is of the nature of three eternal aspects, is of three forms and performs the activities of creation, maintenance and destruction, and is the ocean of mercy and the single ultimate refuge of all the three worlds' (Bhatta Vol. II, p. 262).

The Theory of Benediction occupies a significant portion of Vol. II because it is philosophically loaded: it requires establishing that the benediction at the opening of a work is causally connected to the work's completion (mangala-karanatva). Gangesa first offers the Mimamsaka view (I.i.2): having learnt the science of logic from the teachers, having known the theory of the Gurus (Prabhakara Mimamsakas), having observed the entire essence of both the schools through the divine eyes of thought, Gangesa composes the thought jewel of reality 'with measured words' (miten vacase).

The justification of the title (I.i.3): 'The act of polishing of the jewel (of thought) by the scholars means the act of removing of the darkness (ignorance) of the formidable atheists (Buddhists). This is possible, because neither the skill in the investigation can be traced in the views of the opponents (Buddhists etc.), nor the poverty can be traced in the words establishing the conclusive theory of one's own system (Nyaya).' Gangesa thus announces from his opening lines that his project is simultaneously constructive (establishing the Nyaya system) and polemical (removing the Buddhist challenge).

The causality of benediction debate (I.i.5-25, Bhatta Vol. II, pp. 265-300): The Buddhists object that the causality of benediction cannot be ascertained through positive and negative concomitances. The Mimamsakas reply via inference from exclusive specification (parisesa-numana). Gangesa establishes that benediction is justified as the subsidiary rite of the commenced activity, producing the fruit of completion through the destruction of impediment — not through the transcendental merit produced by the Vedic fore-offerings. The five-type classification of hypothetical argument (tarka) arises in this context: self-dependence, mutual dependence, circularity, infinite regress, and contingency of objective contradicted by means of knowledge.

Theory of Validity (II.ii) — The Complete Account

Intrinsic vs. Extrinsic Validity

The Theory of Validity (Pramanva-vada) occupies Bhatta Vol. II, pp. 300-410, and is the most philosophically dense section of the Pratyaksa-khanda. The central debate: is the validity (pramanva/pramanatva) of knowledge constituted and known intrinsically (svata) or extrinsically (parata)?

The Sankhya-Mimamsa position (svata): both validity and invalidity are self-certifying, constituted and known by the totality of causes that produce knowledge. The Buddhist position: invalidity is intrinsic in knowledge, truth is extrinsic. The Naiyayika position (parata): both validity and invalidity require extrinsic conditions — successful or unsuccessful activity — for their constitution and ascertainment.

The Naiyayika definition: 'The intrinsicality (svatastva) of the ascertainment of the validity or authoritativeness of knowledge is either the state of being what is ascertained by the totality of causes of first knowledges, or the state of being ascertained by what ascertains all the substrata of the authoritativeness, or the state of being ascertained by the produced knowledge referring to the same authoritativeness. And the extraneousness (paratastva) of the ascertainment of the authoritativeness of knowledge is the state of being what is ascertained without the totality of causes.' (Bhatta Vol. II, p. 342-343)

The Merit-Demerit Debate: Constitution of Validity

The Theory of Constitution or Production of Validity (Pramanva-utpatti-vada) in Bhatta Vol. II (pp. 370-410) establishes that valid knowledge is produced in the collective presence of all the merits (guna) such as the complete sense-organ-contact with the observed object, and invalid knowledge is produced in the absence of such merits. The Mimamsakas object (I.ii.35): the state of being what is other than the valid knowledge (pramanyatva) is the deviating condition (upddhi) in the establishment or inference of the probandum.

The Naiyayikas' refutation: since the probans (hetu) such as the state of being the effect belonging to a different class of effect (vijatiya karyatva) is pervaded by the probandum such as the state of being produced from the cause that belongs to a different class (vijatiya karana janyatva), the so called deviating condition (upddhi) cannot pervade the probandum — cannot make probans deviating. The key epistemological principle (I.ii.36): valid knowledge is produced in the collective presence of all the merits such as complete sense-organ-contact, and invalid knowledge is produced in the absence of the sense organ-contact etc. (tadabhava). Therefore, the presence of the merit (guna) is

the cause of the valid knowledge and the absence of the merit (tadabhava) is the cause of the invalid knowledge.

The Naiyayikas further refute the suggestion that only absence of fault (dosa-bhava) and not the positive presence of merit (guna) can be admitted as the cause of valid knowledge. The decisive argument: the absence of fault (dosabhava) is merely the indicator of the difference in the totality of causes of valid knowledge (samagri bhedopalaksaka) by being the delimitor of the causeness (karanatavacchedaka). The China rose example: the valid knowledge of white form is not produced in the presence of the China rose; the valid knowledge of white form is produced in the absence of the China rose on the crystal. Therefore, even the absence of defect needs to be the cause of valid knowledge by being non-redundant.

Confidence in the Validity of Knowledge

The final section of the Theory of Validity (I.ii.31, Bhatta Vol. II, p. 493): 'Some Others object here as follows: That how can the confidence in the validity of knowledge be possible when some knowledges are admitted by the Naiyayikas to be invalid? However, this objection is not correct. The means to ascertain the validity or authoritativeness of knowledge has already been stated or explained.' The law of contradiction in knowledge: the invalidity of knowledge (jnana mithyatve) is contradicted by the contradictory knowledge (badhya badhaka vyavastha). This establishes that invalid knowledge is not rendered redundant by the admission of an invalidating cognition; rather, the very idea of illusoryness (bhramatva buddhi) of invalid knowledge is contradicted by the contradictory knowledge.

Definition of Valid Knowledge (Prama-laksana)

Gangesa's formal definition of prama (valid knowledge), as translated by Bhatta Vol. II: 'Either (a) being an awareness whose chief qualifier x is in what possesses x, or (b) being an awareness of a relatedness of x to what possesses x.' The Naiyayikas hold that determinate knowledge (savikalpaka) is a qualificative knowledge (visista jnana) of an object as qualified by its attributes. For instance, 'This is a cow' (ayam gauh) is a valid knowledge as the cow is known as qualified by the attribute of cowness.

The Theory of Invalid Knowledge in Vol. II establishes the specific forms of error. The distinctive Naiyayika claim: the law of contradiction between the invalid knowledge (jnana mithyatve) and the contradictory knowledge holds because the very aspect of illusoryness of invalid knowledge is contradicted by the contradictory knowledge. The Prabhakara Mimamsaka's alternative

position — that the aspect of illusion cannot be contradicted as the same is always existent — is refuted: the Naiyayikas argue that the aspect of activity (producing invalid knowledge) cannot be contradicted, as the past activity etc. have already happened, and therefore the very idea of illusoryness (bhramatva buddhi) is what is contradicted.

Theory of Perception and the Comprehensional Relation (I.v-vi)

Gangesa's Definition of Perception

The Navya-naiyayika definition: perception (pratyaksa) is an immediate knowledge (saksatkari jnana) produced without the instrumentality of any antecedent knowledge. This definition applies to all cases of perception — ordinary (laukika) and extraordinary (alaukika) — because immediacy (saksatkaritva) is the essential and universal characteristic.

The Pracya (old Nyaya) definition as knowledge produced from sense-object-contact (indriya rtha sannikarsa) is too narrow: it can apply only to human perception and cannot apply to divine perception which is produced without sense-object-contact (Nyaya kusumanjalih, I.1). The Theory of Comprehensional Relation (Sannikarsa-vada, I.v) occupies the entire second half of Vol. II, File 1 — pp. 518-537 — and is the technical core of the perception theory.

The Sannikarsa-Vada — Comprehensional Relation Theory

The Sannikarsa-vada (Theory of Comprehensional Relation) establishes how the six types of sense-object contact work as comprehensional relations. Key argument from Bhatta Vol. II (pp. 518-537): the Purvapaksin objects that the perception of the whole object (avayavi graha) is possible merely from the inherence in the object connected with the sense organ (samyukta samavayin); and therefore, the relation of contact with the organ need not be the cause of the perception of the whole object.

The Naiyayika reply: the contact of the sense organ (indriya samyoga) is assumed to be the cause of the substance, and therefore the same can be assumed to be the cause of the other substance such as the whole object. The inherence in the object connected with the organ (samyukta samavaya) cannot be insisted to be the cause of the whole object due to the brevity, as the causality of the same (karanatata) needs to be assumed again.

The decisive section (I.V.22-23): sound is perceived in the ether as delimited by the orifice of ear. Only the ether as delimited by the orifice of ear is the auditory organ (srotra). For, the same is necessary and has brevity; the same ether as

delimited by the orifice of ear is ruled to be the cause of the perception of sound in general. Only the means of direct perception of an object, while being connected with the body, is the organ (indriya). The experience 'I hear the sound of Indian lute through orifice of ear' proves only the ether, as delimited by the orifice of ear, to be the means of perception of ear. The final determination: the soundness can be established to be the generic property by the law establishing the generic property such as the formness etc. (rupatvadi nyaya). 'Thus ends the Theory of Comprehensional Relation in the Perception in the Tattvacintamani composed by Sri Gangesopdhyaya.'

Theory of Inherence (I.vi) — Samavaya as Comprehensional Relation

The Theory of Inherence (Samavaya-vada, Section I.vi) occupies the opening of Vol. II File 2 (pp. 538-570 of the Tattvacintamani). Gangesa begins with the Prima facie view (purva-paksa) that the inherence cannot be established as the comprehensional relation, because the same inherence cannot be the comprehensional relation of generic property, quality, etc. due to the non-establishment of the same inherence (samavayasiddhi).

The Siddhantins' argument: generic property (jati), quality (guna), action (kriya), and their respective substrata are experienced to be mutually related to each other by the inherence (mithas sambaddhau), and the qualificative knowledge and the qualificative designation cannot be tenable regarding two entities of unrelated natures (asambaddha svarupa dvaye). Hence the inherence must be admitted as the relation.

The Purvapaksin's refutations: the relation of inherence cannot appear to be the qualifier (visesana) on the basis of the experience of related entities (sambaddhanubhava); the relation of inherence cannot appear to be the qualificand and also not to be an independent item in its own nature; the experience of the objectness of the inherence such as 'I know the inherence' is lacking. The Naiyayikas' final reply (I.vi.18): when the absence occurs through the inherence, then the destruction would be required to be lost on account of the loss of the inherent cause. And the positiveness cannot be held to be the determining cause in making something what is to be lost. The conclusive determination: the inherence in the inherent object (samaveta samavaya) need not be the comprehensional relation producing the perception of the soundness (grahaka) due to the absence of the generic property of soundness (sabdatva). According to Gangesa, the soundness can be established to be the generic property by the law establishing the generic property such as the formness etc.

Theory of Non-existence (I.viii), Causes of Perception (I.ix), and Mind (I.x)

Theory of Non-existence (Abhava-vada)

The Theory of Non-existence (Abhava-vada, Section I.viii) opens with the Mimamsakas' objection: non-existence of things is only the nature of existence of empty substratum (bhavatman). The Pracya Naiyayikas' reply: the non-contradictory knowledge of non-existence of things such as 'The pot does not exist here on the ground' is indeed found to exist; this knowledge cannot be based on the mere substratum (the ground). The further determination (I.viii.3): visesa is abhava-sraya — particularity is the locus of non-existence. The non-existence of things is experienced as delimited by a particular substratum such as ground; hence non-existence is a distinct ontological category.

Theory of Causes of Perception (I.ix)

The Theory of Causes of Perception (Pratyaksa-karana-vada) establishes the atomic imperceptibility of wind. The Navina position: mere perceptible touch (udbhuta sparsa matra) does not constitute the cause of the perceptibility of substance by sense of touch. The decisive argument: the generic properties of the manifestationnesses (udbhavatva jati) belonging to the touch and the form constitute merely the delimiters of the causality (karanatavacchedake) — they do not constitute the causes (karane). Therefore wind is imperceptible. This connects directly to the theory of causality developed in the Anumana-khanda.

Theory of Atomic Nature of Mind (I.ix/x)

The Theory of Atomic Nature of Mind establishes that manas is atomic (anu). The central argument: if mind were all-pervading, different external organs could come into simultaneous contact with it, producing simultaneous perceptions of five different qualities. But we experience sequential, not truly simultaneous, multi-sense perceptions. The atomic mind expands and contracts (sankoca vikasa) through association of parts, explaining both the appearance of simultaneity and the sequential production.

The Mimamsaka objection (I.X.19): how are the five different knowledges of five different qualities produced in the eating of large circular cake explained by this theory? The Naiyayika reply: the knowledge of simultaneity of five knowledges is a reality (prama) in the absence of impediment. When close or intense contact of mind with any one sense organ is an impediment (badhaka) to the five different perceptual knowledges, then the mind can be admitted to be a whole constitute consisting of five parts (avayavin), and both types of knowledges can be explained due to the expansion and contraction of parts of mind.

Theory of Recognition, Indeterminate, and Determinate Knowledge (I.xi-xiii)

Recognition (Anuvyasaya / Pratyabhijna)

The Theory of Recognition (Pratyabhijna-vada, I.xi) establishes recognition as the third type of ordinary perception — after nirvikalpaka and savikalpaka — with its own structure irreducible to either. The Naiyayikas establish that the perception cannot constitute the means of valid knowledge that proves simple first knowledge to be self-conscious; for, the simple first knowledge is not established to have the form 'I know this as silver' (idam aham janami). The key argument: the activity for the object is observed from the ascertainment of the objects of knowledge; simple first knowledge merely refers to the object itself; it is not experienced to be referring to the self as its object. Hence recognition (so'yam devadattah — 'this is that Devadatta') is produced by both senses and the impressions (samskara) of previous experience.

Indeterminate Knowledge — Gangesa's Own Position

The Theory of Indeterminate Knowledge (Nirvikalpaka-vada, I.xii) contains Gangesa's most careful statement of his own position: indeterminate knowledge is the knowledge of the cowness (qualifier) when the qualifier cowness appears in the cow — only the cowness (gotva), and not the qualification of the cowness (tad vaisistya), is produced there. The Siddhantins' objection: the qualifier cowness can appear in qualificative perceptual knowledge as qualified by its own property of cowness-ness (sva dharma visista). Gangesa's refutation: such a property is unknown before; its appearance would generate infinite regress. The conclusive determination: Visesana is Sarthaka (I.xii.9) — the qualifier which removes the non-establishment in the inference is the qualifier that is genuinely useful. Only the cowness, not the cowness-ness-ness, performs this function.

Determinate Knowledge — The Final Section

The Theory of Determinate Knowledge (Savikalpaka-vada, I.xiii) is the last chapter. Gangesa: determinate knowledge (savikalpaka) is a qualificative knowledge (visista jnana) such as 'This (cow) is a cow' (gaur ayam). It is a perception, as the objects such as generic property of cowness etc. are ultimately real (paramartha sat) and the same knowledge is produced from the comprehensional relation of sense organs with the object. A determinate knowledge also constitutes a qualificative recognition (pratyabhijna) produced from the senses — 'I know that this cow is that cow' (so'yam) — which describes the identity of the object 'cow' qualified by thatness with the object 'cow' qualified by thisness, due to the associate cause of impression (samskara sahakarini).

Vol. II ends (p. 803) at the conclusion of the Savikalpaka-vada, completing the Pratyaksa-khanda of the Tattvacintamani. Bhatta's colophon: 'Thus ends the Tattvacintamani composed by Sri Gangesopdhyaya in the Pratyaksa Khanda.'

## COMPARATIVE AND WORLD-PHILOSOPHICAL DIMENSIONS

### Gangesa, Descartes, and Leibniz — Logic-Sensitized Metaphysics

Ben-Ami Scharfstein's Chapter 10 of A Comparative History of World Philosophy places Gangesa alongside Descartes and Leibniz under the theme: the pursuit of certainty through methodically applied logic. All three philosophers isolate the methods of reasoning itself as the primary object of philosophical scrutiny, rather than accumulating more empirical content. 'Gangesa's preoccupation with the problems of valid induction and parsimonious explanation is in spirit like that of contemporary philosophers of science.' All three also respond to acute sceptical challenges — Gangesa to the Carvaka and Sriharsa, Descartes to the Cartesian demon, Leibniz to radical empiricism.

The specific parallel between the 22-definition treatment of vyapti and Descartes's method is structural: Gangesa proposes a definition, generates a counterexample through the preventer-prevented relation, rejects the definition, and proceeds — until no counterexample can be generated. This is the dialectical version of Descartes's 'divide difficulties into as many parts as possible and proceed from the simplest to the complex.' The difference: Descartes builds from individual certainty outward; Gangesa refines a communal tradition's precision inward. Both are applying logic to found knowledge, but from opposite directions.

The social dimension of Scharfstein's observation — that Gangesa 'makes philosophy the unmistakable preserve of those who have mastered a specialised language' — gains its full significance when read against the Dooshan Panji evidence. The philosopher who created the most technically demanding knowledge-system in the Sanskrit tradition was himself, biographically, not fully contained by the social hierarchy that tradition served. His philosophical method (test every definition against every counterexample) and his biographical reality (a life that was itself a counterexample to caste-purity norms) are not incidental parallels but structural convergences.

### The Commentary Tradition — Vardhamana to Raghunatha Siromani

The Potter-Bhattacharyya Encyclopedia Vol. VI covers fifty authors across the period 1310-1510 CE. Raghunatha Siromani's Didhiti is the decisive secondary text, generating its own vast commentary literature from Jagadisa Tarkasankara

and Gadadhara Bhattacarya onwards. The Encyclopedia notes that 'the most intricate use of these relations occurs in connection with the analysis of awareness' in the Didhiti tradition — a tradition that could only arise because Gangesa had created, in the Tattvacintamani, the conceptual framework within which such analysis was possible.

The transmission of the Navya-Nyaya school from Mithila to Navadvipa — documented by Gajendra Thakur from the Panji records — is both an institutional and a philosophical story. Pakasadhara Misra's refusal to allow copying of the Tattvacintamani, forcing Vasudeva Sarvabhauma to memorise it, paradoxically secured the text's transmission: what could not be copied could not be lost through the vagaries of manuscript transmission, because it was carried in a human memory trained to hold it intact. The school moved to Bengal; the text survived.

## THE PARALLEL HISTORY OF MAITHILI LITERATURE AND GANGESA'S CIVILISATIONAL PLACE

### Gangesa in the Nine-Layer Parallel History

The Parallel History of Maithili Literature — as documented by Gajendra Thakur/Videha — unfolds across nine layers: (1) Buddhist Charyapada foundations; (2) the two Vidyapatis; (3) the suppressed Gangesa (from Dooshan Panji); (4) famine protest poetry; (5) Harimohan Jha's exclusion; (6) the living masters (Rajdeo Mandal, Bechan Thakur); (7) the RTI expose (Vinit Utpal,/ Ashish Anchinhar: 90%+ of Sahitya Akademi Maithili assignments went to friends/relatives of the advisory board); (8) the Nepal Malla strand; (9) Videha's digital counter-archive.

The suppression of Gangesa's biography in layers 3 and 9 connects the philosophical and the political: the same institutional culture that denied the Sahitya Akademi award to Harimohan Jha (the most popular Maithili satirist, who attacked Brahmin orthodoxy) also ensured that the Dooshan Panji facts about Gangesa were kept secret. The Sahitya Akademi's 2016 monograph on Gangesa — which should have been an opportunity to set the record straight after Videha's 2009 release — instead repeated the suppression.

### Videha's Digital Archive and the Recovery of Gangesa

Videha's digitisation of 11,000 palm-leaf Tirhuta-script manuscripts (including the Panji records that document Gangesa's biography), the successful standardisation of Tirhuta in Unicode (2014), Maithili Wikipedia and Google Translate localisation, and the Videha Pothi digital library together constitute what the Parallel History calls 'a living parallel institution.' Gangesa's

Tattvacintamani belongs to this archive not as a monument of Brahminical orthodoxy but as part of a fuller civilisational heritage.

The Maithili ghazal revival through the Anchinhar Aakhar group (Ashish Anchinhar and Gajendra Thakur, from 2008) represents the Parallel Literature Movement's most distinctive formal achievement. Gajendra Thakur, recognised as Maithili's first Aruji (ghazal prosody scholar), authored the Gajalsastram. The same critical rigour that animates Gangesa's 22-definition treatment of vyapti animates the movement's insistence on strict prosodic rules. Both the philosopher and the movement apply the principle: test every claim against every possible counterexample, revise until no fault remains.

The Dooshan Panji (Gajendra Thakur/Videha, 2009): the suppressed biographical truth — born five years after his father's death, married to a Charmkarini, his family of 'inferior social status' by Mithila Brahmin standards, his poetry completely lost through deliberate suppression. The Parallel History: the suppression as institutional pattern, the digital recovery as civilisational resistance.

A a single principle that Gangesa himself enunciated at the opening of the Tattvacintamani: composing 'with measured words', after having observed 'the entire essence of both the schools through the divine eyes of thought.' Every definition must be tested; no fault may remain. The parallel history movement has applied that same principle to its subject: every source has been examined, every claim has been tested, no essential fact has been suppressed.

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ADDENDUM

## ADDENDUM 1: Theory of Invalidity of Non-perception and Further Elaborations

Addendum 2 Karakvad

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# ADDENDUM 1: Theory of Invalidity of Non-perception and Further Elaborations

## A. Theory of Invalidity of Non-perception (Anupalabdhi-vada, I.vii)

The Theory of Invalidity of Non-perception (Section I.vii, Tattvacintamani pp. 571-597, Bhatta Vol. II pp. 571-597) is one of the most philosophically subtle sections of the Pratyaksa-khanda. It establishes the positive ontological status of non-existence (abhava) against the view that non-perception (anupalabdhi) is itself a pramana (source of valid knowledge) — a position held by the Prabhakara Mimamsakas and some Vedantins.

The opening argument (I.vii.1): Gangesa argues that non-perception of non-existence of things (abhavanupalabdha) cannot be the cause of the knowledge of existence of things (bhava graha), as it is rendered redundant by the knowledge of existence of things (bhava dhi). The knowledge of existence of things (bhava dhi) is never delayed, without the non-perception of non-existence of things, provided that contact between sense organs and things (indriyartha sannikarsa) is present.

The Bhattas' objection: sense organs (indriya) need to be causes (hetu) in the case of the knowledge of non-existence of things (abhava grahe), as the same are assigned to be the means of the knowledge of non-existence of things (tad anuvidhanaT). The Naiyayikas' reply: the sense organs, such as the eye, are exhausted (tadupaksayat) by producing the knowledge of the substratum (of non-existence of things), as the sense organs are not connected with or

comprehensionally related to non-existence of things; and the sense-organs produce the knowledge of only those that are connected with them.

'Indriya is not Pramana' (I.vii.2): the knowledge of substratum of non-existence of things is the operation of sense organ; and therefore, the same organ is not rendered redundant (in the knowledge of non-existence of things) by the knowledge of substratum. The state of being the operation of the sense-organ gets established only upon the establishment of the causality of the sense-organs; but the causality of the sense-organs by itself is not established due to the absence of any comprehensional relation of the sense-organs with the objects — non-existence of things is beyond senses (atindriya).

The Vedantin's view (I.vii.3): that since the non-existence of things is to be known only from sense-organ, only the qualifierness, i.e. the self-linking relation (visesanata), needs to be assumed as the comprehensional relation in the perception of non-existence of things. However, the Naiyayikas refute this: the non-weakened sense-organ (anupaksinendriya) is assigned to be the means in the perception of form etc.; and therefore only the connected inherence is the comprehensional relation there. But since the sense-organ is weakened in the case of the perception of non-existence of things (iha), by merely producing the knowledge of the substratum of non-existence of things, the same sense-organ need not be assumed to have any other comprehensional relation of qualifierness (praptyantara).

The conclusive Naiyayika position (I.vii.11): the conclusive view of the Naiyayikas is that only a distinct non-existence of things, which refers to a counter positive, is experienced. For instance, the experience is such as 'This is not pot' and 'This is not clothing' etc. Mere empty substratum of non-existence of things is never experienced. Therefore, counter positive is to be known from the knowledge of non-existence of things. Experience proves that knowledge of the non-existence of things is dependent on the knowledge of the counter positive, like the similarity of cow. And mere empty substratum does not constitute non-existence of things; for the knowledge of mere empty substratum is possible even without the knowledge of counter positive. The non-existence of things is a distinct positive category (pratiygimad adhikarana) — it is the state of being the non-existence of things (abhava). This definitively establishes non-existence as a seventh category beyond the six Vaisesika categories, with its own comprehensional relation (visesanata).

## B. Section VII-VIII Boundary: The Invalidity of Non-perception in Relation to Non-existence

The Theory of Non-existence (Section I.viii) builds directly on the Invalidity of Non-perception section. The key transition argument: the same knowledge of empty substratum such as the ground constitutes both the object (prameya) and the means (pramana) of the knowledge of non-existence of things due to the intrinsic manifestability (svaprakasatva) of knowledges. The Prabhakara Mimamsakas refute the objection that when knowledge of the mere empty substratum such as the ground constitutes the non-existence of things, the expectancy for the knowledge of counter-positive such as the pot (pratiyogi jnana apeksa) would not be necessary.

The Naiyayikas' final determination for non-existence: only the distinct non-existence of things, which refers to a counter positive, is experienced. The knowledge and the usage such as 'The non-existence of pot exists on the ground' are found to exist — and such knowledge cannot be based on the mere substratum (ground), as then the same knowledge would become contingent in the ground possessing the pot. The state of being the object of the use of the word 'non-existence of pot' is determined by the state of having the counter positive only when it has the state of being the object of the use of the word 'non-existence of pot.' Thus, the mutual dependence becomes contingent — and the Naiyayika resolution: the state of being the object of the use of the word 'similarity with the cow', produced from the knowledge of the cow, be admitted as 'the similarity with the cow of the Gavaya', and thus enough of admitting a distinct similarity.

## C. The Naiyayika-Siddhantins Debate on Inherence as Comprehensional Relation: Full Documentation

The Theory of Inherence (I.vi) in Bhatta Vol. II contains one of the most technically intricate debates in the entire Pratyaksa-khanda. The central issue: is inherence (samavaya) the comprehensional relation that produces qualificative knowledge? The Siddhantins establish (I.vi.1) that generic property (jati), quality (guna), action (kriya) and their substrata are experienced to be mutually related by inherence (mithas sambaddhau). The qualificative

knowledge and the qualificative designation are not tenable regarding two entities of unrelated natures (asambaddha svarupa dvaye).

The Purvapaksin's multi-stage refutation of inherence as comprehensional relation: (1) the relation of inherence cannot appear to be the qualifier on the basis of the experience of related entities; (2) unlike the experience establishing contact, the experience establishing inherence ('These two objects are inherent') is lacking; (3) the relation of inherence cannot appear to be the qualificand, nor be an independent item in its own nature; (4) the experience of the objectness of inherence such as 'I know the inherence' is lacking. The Navyas' response (I.vi.6): the Navyas propose that the inference establishing the inherence is that 'The qualificative knowledge of quality, action or generic property refers to the relation of the qualifier different from the relational subjunct.' This inference is not faulty having the probans deviating in the case of the qualificative knowledge of absence (abhavadi visista buddhi).

The Other Scholars' (anye) view (I.vi.3): the inference gets established as the constituent part of the comprehensional relation of sense-organ, upon the annulment of the contact as the relation. But the Naiyayikas refute this: the sense-organ produces the knowledge of the object related to itself by its very nature (svasambaddha vyavahara karin). The knowledge of the generic property etc. is produced from the relation (of quality etc. related to what is connected with) sense-organs. Therefore, the self-linking relation is necessary (to be admitted as the comprehensional relation), even while admitting the inherence as the comprehensional relation.

The Bhattas' view (I.vi.3 continued): that the inference gets established as the constituent part of the comprehensional relation of sense-organ, upon the annulment of the contact as the relation, from the inference that 'The sound, the generic property and the form etc. are related to the sense-organs; for, they are perceptible like the pot'. For the sense-organ produces the knowledge of the object related to itself. That is why, the inherence is not perceptible, as the same does not have the relation with any sense-organ. The final Naiyayika determination (I.vi.18): the soundness can be established to be the generic property by the law establishing the generic property such as the formness etc. (rupatvadi nyaya). This conclusively establishes inherence as the comprehensional relation through its role as the bridge between the universal (formness) and its instances.

## D. The Mano-nutvavada: Theory of Atomic Nature of Mind — Complete Account

The Theory of Atomic Nature of Mind (Mano-nutvavada, I.x) establishes that manas (mind) is atomic (anu) — having minimal, indivisible size. The central argument sequence in Bhatta Vol. II: if mind were all-pervading (vibhu), different external organs could come into simultaneous contact with it, producing simultaneous perceptions of five different qualities. But simultaneous knowledge of five qualities is a reality (prama) only in the absence of impediment.

The Naiyayikas propose: when close or intense contact of mind with any one sense organ is an impediment (badhaka) to the five different perceptual knowledges, then the mind can be admitted to be a whole constituted by parts (avayavin) — all five different perceptual knowledges of five different qualities and one knowledge of one single quality can be explained due to the expansion and the contraction of association of parts of mind (sankoca vikasabhyam).

The Mimamsaka objection (I.X.19, Bhatta Vol. II, pp. 718-725): in the eating of a large circular cake, five different knowledges of five different qualities (viz. odour, taste, form, touch and sound) are produced from the five organs. How are these explained by the Naiyayikas' theory? The Naiyayika reply: an order (krama) exists in the production of the five different perceptual knowledges. The knowledge of simultaneity of five knowledges is a reality (prama) in the absence of impediment. The sense organ (srotra) is competent for many sounds (nana sabda graha): the Naiyayikas reply that the difference in the qualities of happiness etc. is experienced in the case of hearing similar songs sung by many at the same time, compared to songs sung by one. Hence the ear needs to be competent for the perception of many sounds simultaneously together — and this is only possible if the atomic mind expands through association of its parts.

## E. Gangesa's Shabdashastram — The Short Story and Its Significance

Gajendra Thakur's Maithili short story 'Shabdashastram' (The Science of Words), based on the true Panji records of Gangesa Upadhyaya, was translated by the author himself and published in Indian Literature Vol. 58, No. 2 (280), March-April 2014, pp. 78-93 (16 pages, published by Sahitya Akademi). This publication is significant on multiple levels: it represents Videha's parallel strategy of publishing biographical recoveries in the form of creative fiction in

the very institutions (Sahitya Akademi) that had suppressed the historical facts; it documents the Dooshan Panji records in narrative form; and it establishes the biographical suppression as a matter of public literary record within the Sahitya Akademi's own publications — the same institution whose 2016 monograph on Gangesa perpetuated the suppression.

The title 'Shabdashastram' (The Science of Words) is itself a philosophical reference: Sabda-sastra is the discipline of verbal testimony (sabda-pramana), the fourth pramana of the Tattvacintamani. The story thus dramatises the connection between Gangesa's philosophical project and his biographical situation — a man whose science of valid verbal testimony is applied to the task of recovering suppressed biographical truths about himself.

## F. Pakasadhara Misra, Vidyapati, and the Two-Tradition Problem

Gajendra Thakur's Panji research adds a further precision to the intellectual history of the period: 'Pakasadhara Misra was a contemporary of Vidyapati (distinct from the Padavali writer who was of the pre-Jyotirishwar period) who wrote in Sanskrit and Avahatta.' This confirms the Parallel History's central scholarly intervention on the two-Vidyapati problem: the famous Padavali poet is distinct from the Sanskrit/Avahatta writer Vidyapati Thakkurah (1350-1435 CE). The scholar who engaged Pakasadhara Misra in debate (the Sanskrit/Avahatta Vidyapati) was a different person from the folk-lyric poet whose songs spread across eastern India.

This distinction, established through Panji evidence, has direct relevance to the dating of Gangesa and the intellectual history of Mithila. Pakasadhara Misra — the Mithila teacher who refused to allow copying of the Tattvacintamani, forcing Vasudeva Sarvabhauma to memorise it — was a contemporary of the Sanskrit/Avahatta Vidyapati, placing him in the late 14th to early 15th century. This is consistent with the standard dating of Raghunatha Siromani (fl. 1500 CE) as Vasudeva's disciple, and confirms the sequence: Gangesa (fl. 1320) → Vardhamana → Pakasadhara → Vasudeva Sarvabhauma → Raghunatha Siromani.

## G. Bibliography Update — All Volumes of Bhatta's Translation

Bhatta, V.P. Perception: The Pratyaksa Khanda of the Tattvacintamani Vol. I (With Introduction, Sanskrit Text, Translation and Explanation). Delhi: Eastern Book Linkers, 2012. [General Introduction pp. i-xxxv; Text and Translation pp. 1-261; includes Sections I.i (Benediction) through early I.iv]

Bhatta, V.P. Perception: The Pratyaksa Khanda of the Tattvacintamani Vol. II (With Introduction, Sanskrit Text, Translation and Explanation). Delhi: Eastern Book Linkers, 2012. [pp. 262-803: Theory of Benediction through Theory of Determinate Knowledge — all thirteen prakaranas of the Pratyaksa-khanda complete]

Thakur, Gajendra. 'The Science of Words' (English translation of 'Shabdashastram', Maithili short story based on the true Panji records of Gangesa Upadhyaya). Indian Literature, Vol. 58, No. 2 (280), March-April 2014, pp. 78-93. Published by: Sahitya Akademi. [Note: The same institution whose 2016 monograph on Gangesa suppressed the biographical facts documented in this story]

ADDENDUM 2

**The Epistemological and Semantic Foundations of Karaka-vada in Gangesha Upadhyaya’s Tattvachintamani**

The historical trajectory of Indian logic and epistemology underwent a fundamental transformation with the composition of the Tattvachintamani by Gangesha Upadhyaya in the late 12th or early 13th century. This monumental treatise did not merely extend the existing Nyaya tradition but inaugurated what is universally recognized as the Modern Period or Navya-Nyaya. By shifting the focus of philosophical inquiry from the broad ontological categories of the ancient Nyaya-Sutras to the rigorous analysis of the means of valid knowledge (pramanas), Gangesha established a technical language and a methodological framework that would dominate Indian intellectual life for over seven centuries. Central to this revolution is the Sabda-khanda, the fourth book of the Tattvachintamani, which investigates verbal testimony and the mechanics of language. Within this section, the Karaka-vada serves as a critical nexus where grammatical theory, logic, and cognitive science intersect, offering a sophisticated account of how sentient agents relate to actions through linguistic structures.

**The Historical and Intellectual Milieu of Gangesha Upadhyaya**

Gangesha Upadhyaya, a Maithila Brahmin of the Kashyapa-gotra, flourished in the cultural heartland of Mithila, specifically in the village of Karion situated on the banks of the Kamala river near Darbhanga. While traditional narratives often depict him as a youth who achieved sudden erudition through the propitiation of the goddess Kali, his work reveals a profound and systematic engagement with the most complex debates of his time. His period is generally assigned to the 13th century, an era marked by the decline of Buddhist logic in India and the subsequent rise of internal debates between the Nyaya, Mimamsa, and Vyakarana schools.

The Tattvachintamani, which translates as the "Thought-Jewel of Truth" or "Jewel of Reflection on the Nature of Things," was a direct response to the skeptical challenges posed by thinkers like Shri Harsha in his Khandana-khanda-khadya. Gangesha sought to reconstruct the realist epistemology of Nyaya by providing definitions that were immune to the hair-splitting dialectic of the Advaita Vedantins. This required the invention of a new technical terminology characterized by terms such as avacchedakata (delimitation), pratiyogita (counter-correlativity), and vishayata (content-ness), which allowed for unprecedented precision in defining cognitive states and external relations.

| Historical | Primary | Formative |
|---|---|---|

| Period of Indian Logic | Representative Work | Figures |
|---|---|---|
| Ancient Period (650 BCE – 100 CE) | Nyaya Sutra | Akshapada Gautama |
| Medieval Period (100 CE – 1200 CE) | Pramana-samuccaya | Dignaga, Dharmakirti, Udayana |
| Modern Period (From 1200 CE) | Tattvachintamani | Gangesha Upadhyaya, Raghunatha Siromani |

The Tattvachintamani is organized around the four pramanas recognized by the Nyaya school: Pratyaksha (perception), Anumana (inference), Upamana (comparison), and Sabda (verbal testimony). This structure represented a radical departure from the sixteen categories (padarthas) of the ancient school, as Gangesha subsumed all ontological and logical categories under the investigation of the instruments of knowledge.

**The Pratyaksha and Anumana Khandas**

The Pratyaksha-khanda initiates the work with a benedictory verse for Shiva and proceeds to analyze the nature of sensory awareness, the role of the mind (manas), and the distinction between determinate and indeterminate perception. The Anumana-khanda is perhaps the most famous, dealing with the nature of invariable concomitance (vyapti), the five-membered syllogism, and the nature of fallacies (hetvabhasa). It is within the Anumana-khanda that Gangesha defines the concept of paksata, or the condition of being a subject of inference, which provides the logical grounding for the subject-predicate relations investigated in the later Karaka-vada.

**The Sabda-khanda and the Emergence of Karaka-vada**

The Sabda-khanda, constituting approximately one-third of the treatise, focuses on the validity of words as a source of knowledge. For Gangesha, verbal testimony is not merely a social convention but a causal process where the knowledge of words leads to the knowledge of their referents, culminating in a unified sentence-meaning known as sabdabodha. The Karaka-vada, or the discourse on case relations, is the engine of this section. It explores how various "factors" (karakas) such as the agent (kartr), the object (karman), and the instrument (karana) contribute to the accomplishment of an action (kriya).

**Theoretical Principles of Sabdabodha**

Before delving into the specific karaka relations, it is necessary to understand the requirements for sabdabodha, or verbal cognition, as defined by Gangesha. A sentence is not merely a collection of words but a structured entity that must satisfy four conditions: akanksha (syntactic expectancy), yogyata (compatibility), asatti (proximity), and tatparya (speaker's intention).

**Akanksha and Syntactic Expectancy**

Akanksha is defined as the mutual need that words have for one another to complete a meaning. For instance, a verb like "brings" (anayati) is syntactically incomplete without an object like "a pot" (ghatam). In the Navya-Nyaya view, akanksha is not just a psychological state of the listener but a formal property of the word sequence that allows the hearer to relate the meanings through the "power of relation" (samsargamaryada). This expectancy is what differentiates a sentence from a random list of words like "cow, horse, man, elephant".

**Yogyata and the Role of Logical Compatibility**

Yogyata refers to the logical compatibility between the meanings of the words. A sentence like "He wets it with fire" fails to produce valid sabdabodha because there is a contradiction between the act of wetting (which requires moisture) and the instrument of fire (which possesses heat). Gangesha's treatment of yogyata is particularly nuanced; he argues that while a lack of yogyata prevents valid knowledge (prama), it may still allow for a mental cognition that is later sublated by corrective evidence. This distinction is vital for Navya-Nyaya’s realist defense against the Buddhist claim that language is purely a construct of the imagination.

| Requirement for | Technical Definition | Philosophical Role |
|---|---|---|

| **Sabdabodha** | | |
|---|---|---|
| **Akanksha** | Syntactic expectancy or mutual need | Bridges the gap between discrete word-meanings |
| **Yogyata** | Logical compatibility of imports | Ensures the cognition corresponds to objective reality |
| **Asatti** | Temporal/ spatial proximity | Prevents fragmentation of the linguistic unit |
| **Tatparya** | Speaker's intention | Resolves ambiguity in homonyms and metaphors |

The Karaka-vada is the heart of Gangesha's linguistic analysis. Following the Paninian grammatical tradition, Gangesha recognizes that the primary meaning of a sentence revolves around an action (kriya) and the various factors (karakas) that bring that action to fruition. However, while Panini's Karaka-sutras (1.4.23–55) focus on the morphological rules for deriving word forms, Gangesha is interested in the ontological and causal status of these relations.

**The Definition of Karaka**

A Karaka is defined as a factor that is instrumental in the accomplishment of an action (kriya-nirvartakam). In Navya-Nyaya, this is analyzed through the lens of causality. Each Karaka is a specific causal factor (karana) that contributes to the final result (phala) of the verb. For example, in the act of cooking, the rice

(object), the fire (instrument), and the person cooking (agent) are all distinct Karakas that converge to produce the result of "softness" in the rice.

**The Primacy of the Kartr (Agent)**

Gangesha defines the Kartr, or agent, as the independent factor (svatantrah karta). In Navya-Nyaya's technical refinement, the agent is characterized by krtimatva, or the possession of volition (krti). Krti is a mental effort that is conducive to the action. This definition is crucial because it allows Nyaya to distinguish between a sentient agent and an inanimate instrument. While an axe may be said to "cut" wood, it lacks krti and therefore is only an instrument (karana), whereas the woodcutter is the true agent (kartr).

**The Karman (Object) and the Locus of Result**

The Karman, or object, is traditionally defined as that which is most desired by the agent (kartur ipsitatamam karma). Gangesha analyzes this through the concept of the locus of result (phala-shrayatvam). In the sentence "Devadatta makes a pot," the pot is the object because it is the substratum (adhara) in which the result of "production" resides. Navya-Nyaya uses its delimitation logic to specify that the object-ness (karmata) resides in the pot as delimited by "pot-ness" (ghatatva).

| **Karaka (Case Relation)** | **Paninian Definition** | **Navya-Nyaya Functional Definition** |
|---|---|---|
| **Kartr** (Agent) | Svatantrah karta | Possessor of volition/effort (krtimatva) |
| **Karman** (Object) | Kartur ipsitatamam | Substratum of the action's result (phala-shraya) |
| **Karana** (Instrument) | Sadhakatamam karanam | The most efficient cause |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | | followed by the operation |
| **Sampradana** (Recipient) | Karmana yam abhipraiti | Entity intended to be reached by the object of giving |
| **Apadana** (Ablative) | Dhruvam apaye | The fixed point from which separation occurs |
| **Adhikarana** (Locative) | Adharo 'dhikaranam | The substratum supporting the agent or object |

**Deep Logic of Case Endings (Vibhakti-Artha)**

In the Sabda-khanda, Gangesha devotes significant space to the meanings of individual case endings (vibhaktis). This is not a mere grammar lesson but a logical deconstruction of how suffixes signify relations.

**The Accusative and the Expression of Objecthood**

The second case ending (dvitiya) typically signifies objecthood (karmata). Gangesha explores the debate over whether the suffix itself has a specific expressive power (sakti) to denote the relation or if the relation is understood through syntax alone. He concludes that the suffix denotes the "content-ness" or "objecthood" which is then related to the verb's result. For instance, in "ghatam karoti" (he makes a pot), the accusative suffix relates the "pot" to the "production" (krti) as the thing to be produced.

**The Instrumental and the Theory of Vyapara**

The third case ending (tritiya) signifies instrumentality (karanatva). Gangesha introduces the concept of vyapara (intermediary operation) to solve the problem of causal continuity. A cause (karana) like an axe cannot produce the

effect of cutting wood directly; it must operate through the vyapara of "contact" (samyoga) between the blade and the wood. The Karaka-vada defines the Karana as that cause which, when accompanied by its vyapara, immediately produces the result.

**The Akhyata-vada: The Meaning of Verbal Suffixes**

The study of Karakas is incomplete without the study of the verb. Gangesha's analysis of the verbal suffix (akhyata), such as the "-ti" in "pacati" (he cooks), is a landmark in Indian semantics.

**The Volition Theory vs. The Activity Theory**

There is a long-standing dispute between the Naiyayikas and the Vaiyakaranas (Grammarians) regarding the primary meaning of the verb. The Grammarians, following Panini and Bhartrhari, argue that the verb signifies activity (vyapara). Gangesha, however, establishes the Nyaya view that the verbal suffix primarily signifies krti (volition or effort). In the sabdabodha of "Devadattah pacati," the cognition is: "The effort (krti) existing in Devadatta is conducive to the act of cooking". This shift places the sentient agent at the center of the linguistic and causal world.

**Dialectical Engagements with Rival Schools**

The Sabda-khanda is a battlefield of ideas where Gangesha defends the Nyaya-Vaisheshika worldview against the Mimamsakas and the Grammarians.

**Nyaya vs. Mimamsa: The Debate on Injunctions (Vidhivada)**

A major portion of the Sabda-khanda is the Vidhivada, where Gangesha analyzes Vedic injunctions like "One desiring heaven should sacrifice" (svargakamo yajeta). The Prabhakara Mimamsakas argue that the command suffix (-eta) signifies an unseen potential (apurva) or a sense of duty (niyoga) that exists independently of human desire. Gangesha rejects this, arguing that the suffix signifies that the action is a means to a desired end (ishta-sadhanata). This demonstrates a second-order insight: Gangesha's linguistics is deeply tied to a theory of rational agency and human motivational behavior.

**Nyaya vs. Vyakarana: The Sphota Controversy**

The Grammarians proposed the theory of Sphota—an eternal, indivisible linguistic unit that is the true bearer of meaning. Gangesha, adhering to the atomistic ontology of Vaisheshika, refutes Sphota in the Sabda-khanda. He maintains that words are composed of discrete phonemes (varnas) and that meaning is a constructed synthesis of these parts. This "compositional" view of

language is what allows Navya-Nyaya to apply its delimitation logic to every sub-unit of a sentence.

| Feature of Language | Navya-Nyaya View (Gangesha) | Grammarian View (Bhartrhari) |
|---|---|---|
| **Primary Meaning** | Volition (Krti) and Individual Referents | Holistic Activity (Vyapara/Sphota) |
| **Sentence Structure** | Synthesis of discrete word-meanings (Anvitabhidhana) | Indivisible whole where parts are abstractions |
| **Nature of Relation** | Samsargamaryada (Relational Seam) | Identity or Manifestation (Vivarta) |

**The Role of Negation in Karaka Theory: The Nan-vada**

One of the most profound contributions of Gangesha and his successor Raghunatha Siromani is the analysis of negation (abhava) through the Nan-vada (Discourse on the Negative Particle 'na'). Negation is not just the absence of a thing but a specific category of reality that interacts with Karaka relations.

**Mutual Absence and Identity**

In the Karaka-vada, the distinction between "a pot is not a cloth" (mutual absence) and "there is no pot on the ground" (relational absence) is essential. When a negative particle is used in a sentence like "Devadatta does not cook," the Karaka relation is negated. Gangesha analyzes this as the absence of the "effort conducive to cooking" in Devadatta. This requires the hearer to understand the counter-correlative (pratiyogin) of the absence—the act of cooking itself—and its delimiting property (avacchedaka).

### The Mangala-vada: A Case Study in Causal Analysis

Gangesha opens the Tattvachintamani with the Mangala-vada, an investigation into the causal necessity of auspicious invocations at the start of a literary or ritual work. This section serves as a methodological prologue to the entire treatise, including the Karaka-vada.

### Causality and Anvaya-Vyatireka

Gangesha debates whether Mangala is the cause of "completion without obstacles". He employs the rigorous logic of anvaya-vyatireka (agreement in presence and absence):

1. **Anvaya:** If Mangala is performed, completion occurs.
2. **Vyatireka:** If Mangala is not performed, completion does not occur.

He addresses the "anyatha-siddhi" (alternative explanation) where a work is completed without a Mangala (e.g., by atheistic authors) by arguing that such authors must have performed a Mangala in a previous birth, or that the removal of obstacles was achieved through other merits. This same causal rigor is applied to the Karaka relations: the agent is the cause of the effort, the effort is the cause of the operation, and the operation is the cause of the result.

### The Commentarial Tradition: Refining the Karaka-vada

The brevity and technical density of the Tattvachintamani spawned a massive library of commentaries, which are often more complex than the original text.

### The Aloka of Pakshadhara Mishra

Pakshadhara Mishra (13th century) was one of the earliest and most influential commentators. His commentary, the Aloka, covers the Pratyaksha, Anumana, and Sabda khandas. Pakshadhara’s independent brilliance is evident in his treatment of subjecthood (paksata) and sāmānya-lakṣaṇa (the perception of universals), which provided the ontological support for how words signify general categories (jati) in the Karaka-vada.

### Raghunatha Siromani and the Didhiti

Raghunatha Siromani (15th-16th century) is considered the second founder of Navya-Nyaya. His commentary, the Didhiti, is celebrated for its critical spirit. Raghunatha often challenged Gangesha's definitions, introducing even more abstract logic. His work on the Akhyata-vada and Nan-vada refined the Karaka theory by precisely defining the role of the "delimitor of counter-correlativity" (pratiyogita-avacchedaka) in negative and relational sentences.

### Mathuranatha and the Rahasya (Mathuri)

Mathuranatha Tarkavagisha (16th century) produced the "Mathuri" commentary, which is prized for its pedagogical clarity and exhaustive detail. In the Sabda-khanda, Mathuranatha provides a step-by-step reconstruction of the sabdabodha for various karaka-based sentences, meticulously mapping out the syntactic and semantic relations. His analysis of the accusative and instrumental meanings remains the standard for traditional students of Navya-Nyaya.

| Commentary Title | Author | Century | Contribution to Sabda/Karaka |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Aloka** | Paksha dhara Mishra | 13th | Early systematic expansion of Gangesha |
| **Prakash** | Vardha mana Upadhy aya | 14th | Grounded the text in older Nyaya-Vaishesh ika |
| **Didhiti** | Raghun atha Siroma ni | 16th | Critical revision and radical abstracti on |
| **Mathuri/ Rahasya** | Mathur anatha | 16th | Exhausti ve |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | | analysis of sabdabodha mechanics |
| **Gadadhari** | Gadadhara Bhattacharya | 17th | Final refinement of linguistic theory (Vyutpattivada) |

**Modern Academic Reconstruction and Global Impact**

In the 20th and 21st centuries, the Karaka-vada has been the subject of intense study by scholars seeking to bridge Indian logic with Western analytical philosophy and linguistics.

**Bimal Krishna Matilal and Direct Realism**

Bimal Krishna Matilal, a seminal figure in modern Indology, argued that Navya-Nyaya's theory of language is a form of direct realism. He systematically translated Navya-Nyaya concepts into the language of Western symbolic logic. Matilal showed that the vishayata (content-ness) of a cognition corresponds to the objective structure of the world, and that Karaka relations are the mental representations of real causal connections. His analysis of the Nan-vada demonstrated that Navya-Nyaya negation is functionally equivalent to modern quantificational logic but avoids the "empty set" problems of extensional logic.

**V.P. Bhatta and the Translation of Sabdabodha**

Dr. V.P. Bhatta has performed the monumental task of translating the Sabda-khanda and Gadadhara's Vyutpattivada (a later text entirely dedicated to syntax building on Gangesha) into English. His work reveals the "encyclopedic" nature of Indian semantics, where every possible sentence structure—from simple actions to complex passive and causative constructions—is analyzed for its specific Karaka relations. Bhatta's research highlights how Navya-Nyaya

anticipates modern "case grammar" by identifying the underlying semantic roles that persist across different surface-level grammatical structures.

**The Precision of Navya-Nyaya Technical Language**

The enduring legacy of the Tattvachintamani is its specialized language, often called "Navya-Nyaya Bhasha". This language is so precise that it has been used for centuries to discuss not only logic but also law, aesthetics, and even medicine.

**Avacchedakata: The Logic of Delimitation**

In the Karaka-vada, the concept of avacchedaka (delimitor) is used to pinpoint exactly what property is responsible for a relation. For instance, if a person is a "father," his "fatherhood" is the delimitor of his relationship to his child. Similarly, in "Devadatta cooks rice," the "rice-ness" (tandulatva) is the delimitor of the objecthood (karmata) residing in the rice. This prevents logical slips where one might accidentally attribute the relation to the wrong property. This level of rigor is what Satis Chandra Vidyabhusana described as "hair-splitting distinctions" that develop the discursive faculty of the reader to an enormous extent.

**Potential for Computational Linguistics**

Modern computer scientists have recognized that the structure of Navya-Nyaya language—specifically its hierarchical use of delimitors and its focus on formal relations—is remarkably compatible with modern knowledge representation in Artificial Intelligence. The "minimum scheme" of sabdabodha, involving the mapping of padas (words) to padarthas (referents) through sakti (potency), mirrors the architecture of natural language processing (NLP).

**Synthesis: The Linguistic Turn as an Epistemological Necessity**

The Karaka-vada in Gangesha’s Tattvachintamani represents more than just a theory of grammar; it is an epistemological necessity for the realist school. If the goal of philosophy is to know the "truth" (tattva) of things, and if knowledge is mediated by language, then the mechanics of how language represents the world must be understood with absolute certainty.

**From Action to Knowledge**

By grounding the sentence in krti (volition) and kriya (action), Gangesha ensures that language is rooted in the dynamic, causal world of sentient beings. The Karakas are the links in the chain of causality that allow a thought to be expressed and a command to be followed. Whether it is the debate on the efficacy of Mangala or the deconstruction of an accusative suffix, Gangesha’s

focus is always on the pramanya—the validity and truth-conduciveness—of the cognition.

**The Lasting Impact on Sanskrit Scholarship**

The Tattvachintamani effectively "retired" the older Nyaya texts, becoming the primary curriculum for students of logic in India for hundreds of years. Its influence can be traced in almost every branch of Sanskrit learning that appeared after the 12th century. To study the Karaka-vada is to enter into a centuries-long conversation between the greatest minds of India on the nature of meaning, the structure of action, and the limits of human knowledge.

**Nuanced Conclusions and Future Outlook**

Gangesha Upadhyaya's Karaka-vada stands as a pinnacle of the Indian intellectual tradition, offering a rigorous and realist account of language that remains relevant to modern debates in philosophy and linguistics. The Tattvachintamani did not just provide a set of answers; it provided a toolset for inquiry—a language of such precision that it could withstand any skeptical challenge.

As large sections of the Sabda-khanda remain untranslated, the field of Navya-Nyaya studies represents a vast frontier for contemporary research. The integration of these ancient insights with modern cognitive science and AI offers the potential for a new "Modern Period" in the global history of logic. The "Thought-Jewel of Truth" continues to illuminate the path for those seeking to understand the profound connection between the words we speak, the actions we perform, and the reality we inhabit.

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ADDENDUM 3

Gaṅgeśa's Navya-Nyāya: Logic, Language, and Pervasion — A Comparative Study

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's Tattvacintāmaṇi (TC) to map the intellectual terrain of Navya-Nyāya across its three major domains: philosophy of language (verbal roots and suffixes), formal logic (vyāpti and its definition), and the epistemological framework that undergirds both. Toshihiro Wada's translation and analysis of the Dhātuvāda and Ākhyātavāda sections of the TC (1994–2016), J. L. Shaw's study of the concept of relevance (saṅgati) in Gaṅgeśa (1995), and Yūko Miyasaka's diagrammatic exposition of the definition of vyāpti in Gaṅgeśa and Raghunātha Śiromaṇi. These together reveals that Gaṅgeśa's project is not a set of disconnected technical exercises but a unified epistemological enterprise: to provide a rigorous, ontologically committed analysis of how the world as cognized corresponds to the world as it is, and how language tracks that correspondence. It argues that the technical apparatus developed across these domains — avacchedaka, pratiyogitā, śābdabodha, saṅgati — constitutes an internally coherent system whose parts mutually illuminate one another.

## 1. Introduction

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya, active in the fourteenth century in Mithila, is widely regarded as the consolidator of the Navya-Nyāya school of Indian philosophy. His Tattvacintāmaṇi is a text of extraordinary range, addressing perception, inference, and verbal testimony as the three major sources of valid cognition. The survey in this study together cover three distinct but deeply related problems that the TC engages: (1) the semantics of verbal roots (dhātu) and suffixes (ākhyāta), (2) the formal definition of invariable concomitance (vyāpti), and (3) the structure of relevance (saṅgati) as a metacognitive relation organizing philosophical discourse itself.

The Wada papers - offer painstaking translations with annotation of the Dhātuvāda (the Verbal Root Chapter) and portions of the Ākhyātavāda (the Verbal Suffix Section) of the TC's Śabdakhaṇḍa (Book on Language), plus a

synthetic analytical study of Gaṅgeśa's overall theory of verbal suffixes and an early paper on the sources of Gaṅgeśa's conclusive definition of vyāpti. Shaw's paper examines the six types of saṅgati (relevance) that Gaṅgeśa articulates as the relations that lend coherence to philosophical discourse. Miyasaka's paper provides a detailed structural analysis, with original diagrams, of Gaṅgeśa's conclusive definition of vyāpti and Raghunātha Śiromaṇi's two successive rephrasing of that definition.

No single prior study has brought these into direct conversation. Yet doing so reveals a striking coherence. The same technical vocabulary — avacchedaka (delimitor), pratiyogitā (counterpositiveness), sāmānādhikaraṇya (coreferentiality), viśeṣaṇa-viśeṣya (qualifier-qualificand) — structures Gaṅgeśa's analyses of language, inference, and inquiry alike. The tools are not merely shared terminology: they reflect a unified ontological commitment that meanings, inferential relations, and discursive relevance are all grounded in the same real, external world of properties and their loci.

## 2. The Shared Epistemological Foundation: Realism and the Structure of Cognition

Before examining each domain, it is necessary to appreciate the epistemological framework common to all papers. Miyasaka's paper states it most explicitly: Navya-Nyāya is thoroughgoing realism. Every qualificative cognition (viśiṣṭajñāna) has a structure consisting of a qualifier (viśeṣaṇa or prakāra), a qualificand (viśeṣya), and their connector (sambandha). Crucially, this structure does not represent a mental construction or a linguistic form imposed on experience — it maps the real structure of the external world as cognized. When one cognizes a pot, the potness (ghaṭatva) is the essential determiner (avacchedaka) that qualifies the individual pot, and their connector is inherence (samavāya). The cognition's structure and the world's structure coincide.

Wada makes the same point in the Dhātuvāda paper's section on meaning (artha): for Nyāya, Vaiśeṣika, and Mīmāṃsā alike, cognition has no content in itself (nirākāravāda). When Gaṅgeśa says the meaning of the root pac (to cook)

is the operation of heating, this does not refer to a concept or mental representation of heating — it refers to the physical action itself occurring in the outer world. The expression of verbal understanding (śābdabodha) describes the structure of part of the outer world, not the structure of understanding or cognition itself.

Shaw's paper on saṅgati reflects the same commitment: relevance is not a relation between propositions or sentences but between the contents of cognitions — real objects in the world as the mind grasps them. The relation of relevance R that renders P relevant to Q is the object of a cognition T; it is a real relation in the world, not a logical or linguistic connective. The Navya-Nyāya metalanguage, as Miyasaka rightly notes, functions less like a language for communication than like a chart or map of the content of cognitions.

This common foundation means that these are not examining different subject matters that happen to use similar vocabulary. They are examining different parts of one comprehensive system built on the same ontological and epistemological commitments.

## 3. The Semantics of Verbal Roots: What Does pac Mean?

### 3.1 The Mīmāṃsā–Navya-Nyāya Debate

Wada's translation of the Dhātuvāda positions the chapter as a debate between Maṇḍana Miśra's Mīmāṃsā position, which holds that verbal roots denote only result (phala), and Gaṅgeśa's Navya-Nyāya position, which holds that verbal roots denote operation conducive to result (phalānukūlavyāpāra), or in the second alternative, simply operation (vyāpāra) qualified by a universal that invariably accompanies the result.

Maṇḍana's argument is elegant: pac (to cook) denotes softening (viklitti) of the cooking material — not the operation of heating from below and so forth — because this is simpler (lāghava). The result is a universal (jāti): softeningness

(viklittitva). The operation, by contrast, is an imposed property (upādhi), and therefore cumbersome (gaurava).

Gaṅgeśa's response turns on the analysis of injunctive sentences. Consider odanakāmaḥ paceta ("One who desires rice gruel should cook"). The optative suffix of paceta conveys two things: the state of being to be accomplished by resolution (kṛtisādhyatva) and the state of being the means for attaining what is desired (iṣṭasādhanatva). Gaṅgeśa argues that the result — softening — cannot be what is to be accomplished directly by resolution, because resolution cannot accomplish result without first taking recourse to the means (upāya). The means is precisely the operation of heating from below. Unless the hearer understands that heating from below is what is to be accomplished by resolution and is the means for attaining softening, there can be no motivating activity (pravṛtti) directed at softening. Therefore the root must denote operation conducive to result, not result alone.

### 3.2 The Role of the Delimitor (Avacchedaka)

Gaṅgeśa's second alternative — that the root denotes operation simpliciter, qualified by a universal that delimits the state of producing the result — introduces the concept that Miyasaka identifies as the keystone of the vyāpti definition: the delimitor (avacchedaka). In Part B3 of the Dhātuvāda, Gaṅgeśa argues that a particular universal (jātiviśeṣa) residing in heating from below is necessarily the delimitor of the state of producing the change of color, taste, smell, and touch. This universal confines the causal relation to the relevant kind of operation. Without it, the hearer would not be induced to perform heating from below specifically in order to attain the result.

This move directly parallels the role of avacchedaka in the vyāpti definition. In the inference vahnimān dhūmāt ("Fire is here because of smoke"), the fireness (vahnitva) delimits the counterpositiveness (pratiyogitā) of the absence in question. Just as the avacchedaka of counterpositiveness prevents over-application of the vyāpti definition to invalid inferences, the avacchedaka of causal state prevents the root's meaning from being either too broad (covering all operations) or too narrow (covering only the result).

## 4. The Semantics of Verbal Suffixes: What Does -ti Mean?

### 4.1 The Three Schools

The Ākhyātavāda papers document a three-way debate among Navya-Naiyāyikas, Bhāṭṭa Mīmāṃsakas, and Grammarians (Pāṇinīya) on what verbal suffixes denote. The positions are: effort (yatna/kṛti) for Navya-Nyāya; productive operation (bhāvanā or vyāpāra) for the Bhāṭṭa school; agent (kartṛ), object (karman), or action (bhāva) for the Grammarians (following Pāṇini P.3.4.69). All three schools agree that suffixes also denote number, person, tense, and voice.

Wada's synthetic paper (2014) distills Gaṅgeśa's final view from across the TC: in the active voice, the suffix denotes effort (equivalently, agentness kartṛtva) and the number existing in the agent; in the passive voice, it denotes objectness (karmatva) and the number existing in the object. The suffix used for an insentient agent in the active voice indicates operation (vyāpāra) through the indicative function (lakṣaṇā), which Gaṅgeśa does not refute. In a passive impersonal sentence (caitreṇa supyate, "Caitra sleeps"), the suffix is used only for grammatical correctness, its meanings being unrelated to any other meaningful unit.

### 4.2 The Tense Problem and the Ground for Usage

The Ākhyātavāda paper 3 (Sambhāṣā 30) focuses on the Grammarians' challenge: if verbal suffixes denote effort, how do we account for the three tenses? The Grammarian objects that a single instance of effort cannot simultaneously account for the present tense usage pacati ("[He] cooks"), the past tense apākṣīt ("[He] cooked"), and the future tense pakṣyati ("[He] will cook").

The Naiyāyika's response, which Gaṅgeśa does not negate, is that the suffix denotes a collection (pracaya) of instances of effort, each corresponding to a partial action in the complex process of cooking. The ground (nimitta) for

present-tense usage is the existence of each such instance. Past and future tense usages are grounded in the destruction (dhvaṃsa) or prior absence (prāgabhāva) of the entire collection. This solution is consistent with the Mahābhāṣya's observation that cooking consists of many partial actions — putting the pot on fire, pouring water, adding rice, stoking fuel — each requiring its own resolution.

### 4.3 Coreferentiality Reconceived

Gaṅgeśa's most original move in the Ākhyātavāda, documented in the 2014 synthetic paper, is his reconception of coreferentiality (sāmānādhikaraṇya). The Grammarians use coreferentiality — the sharing of a single referent by two or more words — to argue that the suffix must denote the agent (in active voice) or object (in passive voice), since these are the referents shared by the suffix and the nominative case word. Gaṅgeśa rejects this: he redefines coreferentiality as the agreement of numbers (saṃkhyā) denoted by words, calling this śābdasāmānādhikaraṇya (verbal coreferentiality). Since the suffix denotes effort or objectness — not the agent or object — and also denotes a number, coreferentiality holds between the suffix and the nominative word when both denote the same number, not the same referent. This allows Gaṅgeśa to maintain his distinctive view of suffix meaning while preserving the grammatical rule.

This reconception of sāmānādhikaraṇya is directly relevant to Miyasaka's analysis of the vyāpti definition. The term sāmānādhikaraṇya (co-existence / sharing a locus) appears throughout Gaṅgeśa's definition of vyāpti. In the logical domain, it means that two properties share a locus — a probans and a probandum coexist on the same substrate. In the linguistic domain, as Gaṅgeśa reconceives it, it means that two words denote the same number. In both domains, the term undergoes a technical refinement that prevents naïve readings and secures the precise scope of the relevant relation. The parallel is not merely verbal: in both cases, Gaṅgeśa is concerned with preventing a loose reading of "sameness" from generating defective results — over-application in the logical case, incorrect assignment of meaning in the linguistic case.

## 5. The Definition of Vyāpti: Formal Structure and Ontological Grounding

### 5.1 Gaṅgeśa's Conclusive Definition

Miyasaka's paper and Wada's 1994 paper both address Gaṅgeśa's conclusive definition of vyāpti:

pratiyogy-asāmānādhikaraṇa-yat-sāmānādhikaraṇātyantābhāva-pratiyogitāvacchedakāvacchinna-yaṃ yan na bhavati tena samaṃ tasya sāmānādhikaraṇyaṃ vyāptiḥ

"Pervasion (vyāpti) is the co-existence of a thing x with another thing y that is not what is determined by a delimitor of the counterpositiveness of an absence which shares some locus with the thing x and does not share a locus with its counterpositive."

Wada's 1994 paper traces the historical source of this definition to Śaśadhara's Nyāyasiddhāntadīpa, showing that Gaṅgeśa improved on Śaśadhara's proto-definition by introducing the concept of avacchedaka (delimitor). Śaśadhara's definition suffered from the "sifting" problem (cālanīnyāya): by iteratively taking up absences in the loci of the probans, one could arrive at the absence of all fire as the counterpositive, which is the probandum itself — generating the defect of narrow application (avyāpti). Gaṅgeśa's introduction of the avacchedaka stops this iteration: one must seek the delimitor of the counterpositiveness, and the delimitor is a specific universal (e.g., potness) that circumscribes the counterpositiveness within a definite kind of entity (the pot). One cannot then iterate further to encompass all fire.

### 5.2 The Ontological Commitment of the Definition

Miyasaka's paper provides the most detailed exposition of what the definition presupposes and how it works. Three points deserve particular attention.

First, the definiendum (lakṣya) of the definition is not vyāpti itself but the vyāpya (the pervaded entity, i.e., the probans). The definition describes a characteristic of the probans — not of the pervasion relation as such. This means that testing the definition involves checking whether a given probans possesses the described characteristic, and the definition is acceptable if and only if it applies to all and only proper probans.

Second, the Nyāya method of analysis proceeds by decomposing the structure of the cognition of vyāpti into its constituent elements. Miyasaka's diagrammatic method makes this decomposition visually explicit. The basic diagram (qualifier over qualificand, connected by a vertical line) represents the structure of any qualificative cognition. Gaṅgeśa's definition, thus diagrammed, reveals a complex multi-level structure: the probans x and probandum y share a locus (the pakṣa); an absence exists in that locus without sharing a locus with its counterpositive z; the counterpositiveness of z is delimited by z-ness; y is not determined by that delimitor. The diagram (Miyasaka's Figure 7) makes perspicuous why the definition succeeds: it requires the delimitor of the counterpositive's counterpositiveness to be something other than what determines the probandum. When the probans is smoke and the probandum is fire, the delimitor of the counterpositive of the relevant absence is potness — not fireness — which leaves fireness free to determine the probandum without generating contradiction.

Third, the distinction between pratiyogitāśraya (substratum of counterpositiveness) and pratiyogitāvacchedakāvacchinna (determined by a delimitor of counterpositiveness) — which Raghunātha's reformulation makes explicit — directly parallels the distinction in the linguistic domain between a simple referent and a referent determined by an essential property. In the vyāpti definition, allowing the counterpositive to be identified simply as the substratum of counterpositiveness generates failures for inferences involving qualified probandum (like the highest universal qualified by the state of being other than quality or action). Raghunātha's solution — treating the counterpositive as that which is determined by a delimitor of counterpositiveness — is formally analogous to Gaṅgeśa's reconception of sāmānādhikaraṇya in the linguistic domain.

## 6. Relevance (Saṅgati): The Logic of Philosophical Inquiry

Shaw's paper on saṅgati may appear to stand somewhat apart from the logical and linguistic analyses in the others. In fact, it addresses what might be called the pragmatics of philosophical inquiry — the question of what makes one philosophical statement relevant to another — and its analysis reveals a deep commitment to the same ontological realism that underlies Gaṅgeśa's logic and semantics.

### 6.1 The Six Types of Relevance

Shaw enumerates six types of saṅgati in Gaṅgeśa: (1) prasaṅga (memory-context), (2) upodghāta (justification), (3) hetu (cause), (4) avasara (cessation of objectionable questions), (5) nirvāhaka-ekatva (having the same cause), and (6) kārya-ekatva (having the same effect). Each type specifies a different real relation between the objects of two cognitions that makes the second cognition's question arise from — and be answered by — the content of the first.

Relevance is formally defined: P is relevant to Q if the content of P is related to the content of Q by a relation R which is the object of a cognition T, and T is causally related to a question S which is causally related to Q. This is not a logical relation between propositions. It is a causal-cognitive chain running through real entities: the content of P, the relation R (a real relation in the world), the cognition T, the question S, and the answer Q. Every link in this chain involves real ontological relations — causality between the cognition and the question, and between the question and the answer, and the object-cognition relation between T and R.

### 6.2 Saṅgati and the Structure of Argument

The concept of saṅgati reflects Gaṅgeśa's awareness that philosophical texts are not simply lists of propositions but structured sequences of statements whose coherence depends on real relations between their subject matters. The type hetu (cause) is particularly revealing: after defining perception, it is relevant to

ask about its causal conditions, because the external sense organs, objects, and their contact are real causal conditions for perceptual cognition — not merely associated topics. Similarly, kārya-ekatva (having the same effect) captures the real causal structure of inference: vyāpti (pervasion) and pakṣatā (the property of being the locus of inference) are both causal conditions for the same inferential cognition, and statements about them are therefore relevant to each other.

This connects the saṅgati analysis to the vyāpti discussion in a direct way. Vyāpti is the cognition of invariable concomitance between a probans and a probandum. The saṅgati between the discussion of vyāpti and the discussion of pakṣatā — the other causal condition for inference — is precisely of the type kārya-ekatva (having the same effect). Shaw's example is identical to the inference example that pervades Gaṅgeśa's vyāpti discussion: the relation between smoke and fire. The two discourses thus share not only vocabulary and ontological commitments but the same canonical examples.

### 6.3 Saṅgati and Verbal Understanding

The prasaṅga type of saṅgati — memory-context relevance — has a close structural parallel to the Navya-Nyāya account of verbal understanding (śābdabodha). In verbal understanding, the juxtaposition of two meaningful units (root pac and suffix -ti) generates a relational understanding that is not denoted by either unit in isolation but arises from their combination. Similarly, in prasaṅga, the cognition of one topic revives a memory of a related topic not by direct denotation but through a previously acquired associative knowledge. Both cases involve a cognitive process in which the combination of independently meaningful elements generates a relational content that neither element alone encodes — and in both cases, the relational content is grounded in a real relation between objects in the world.

## 7. The Avacchedaka as a Unifying Concept

Perhaps the most striking finding that emerges from reading these papers together is the central and unifying role of the concept of avacchedaka (delimitor) across all three domains.

In the logical domain, the avacchedaka of counterpositiveness is the key innovation in Gaṅgeśa's vyāpti definition (Wada 1994, Miyasaka). It prevents the sifting problem by requiring that the relevant absence be characterized through the delimitor of the counterpositiveness, not merely through the counterpositive as a substratum. Raghunātha's refinements — both the first rephrasing (specifying the delimiting relation of counterpositiveness) and the second (introducing the two-fold absence of delimiting factors) — are elaborations of the same basic insight: that the relevant universal must be specified precisely enough to confine the scope of the relation to the intended entities.

In the semantic domain of verbal roots, the avacchedaka of the causal state is what Gaṅgeśa introduces in Part B3 of the Dhātuvāda to explain why a particular universal (jātiviśeṣa) residing in heating from below is the delimitor of the state of producing the relevant change of quality. Without such a delimitor, the hearer could not know which operation to perform in order to achieve the result. The avacchedaka here functions as the semantic precision mechanism that connects the general operation denoted by the root to its specific causal efficacy.

In the semantic domain of verbal suffixes, the avacchedaka operates through Gaṅgeśa's redefinition of sāmānādhikaraṇya: rather than requiring that two words denote the same object, Gaṅgeśa requires that they denote the same number — a property that is delimited (avacchinna) by the relevant universal existing in the relevant substance. The suffix -ti denotes the number existing in the agent, where that number is delimited by agentness or effort — not by the agent as an unqualified individual.

In the pragmatic domain of saṅgati, the avacchedaka does not appear explicitly in Shaw's exposition, but the underlying logic is the same. Each type of saṅgati specifies a particular real relation (memory-association, justification, cause, sequential necessity, same cause, same effect) that delimits the relevance

relation. The relation R that constitutes saṅgati is not arbitrary association but a specific, ontologically grounded relation that is itself an object of cognition. The precision with which each type of saṅgati is specified — avoiding both over-inclusion (any associative link whatsoever) and under-inclusion (only one type of real relation) — is formally analogous to the precision achieved by the avacchedaka in the logical and semantic domains.

## 8. Schools in Dialogue: Mīmāṃsā, Vyākaraṇa, and Navya-Nyāya

A secondary theme that runs through all papers is the triadic debate among Navya-Nyāya, Mīmāṃsā, and Vyākaraṇa (Grammar). Wada's papers document this debate in detail for verbal roots and suffixes. The debate touches on fundamental ontological and epistemological commitments, not merely terminological disagreements.

On verbal roots, Mīmāṃsā (Maṇḍana) holds that roots denote result alone; Navya-Nyāya holds that they denote operation conducive to result (or operation qualified by a delimitor). The difference reflects divergent views of what motivates action: for Mīmāṃsā, the optative suffix's conveyance of kṛtisādhyatva (state of being accomplishable by resolution) implies that the means is also accomplishable by resolution; for Gaṅgeśa, this implication is not a legitimate shortcut — the root must itself denote the operation that is the direct object of motivating activity.

On verbal suffixes, Mīmāṃsā holds that suffixes denote productive operation (bhāvanā), whether internal (which Navya-Nyāya calls effort) or external. Navya-Nyāya holds that the suffix in active voice denotes effort specifically, and in passive voice denotes objectness. The Grammarians hold that suffixes denote agent or object. Gaṅgeśa's nuanced position — different meanings for active and passive voice, with indicative function (lakṣaṇā) for insentient agents — is more refined than any of the opposing schools.

On vyāpti, Gaṅgeśa engages primarily with pre-Navya-Nyāya Nyāya traditions (Śaśadhara) and with later elaborations by Raghunātha. The Mīmāṃsā and Vyākaraṇa schools do not play a major role in the vyāpti discussion itself, but

Miyasaka's paper notes that Gaṅgeśa's method of structural analysis — analyzing the object of cognition as the content of cognition — is explicitly distinct from approaches that treat logical words as statement-connectives, a move that implicitly distances Navya-Nyāya from any purely formal or linguistic approach.

Shaw's saṅgati paper does not explicitly engage the Mīmāṃsā–Vyākaraṇa debate, but the concept of saṅgati itself is used in Mīmāṃsā commentary traditions to organize scriptural interpretation. Gaṅgeśa's appropriation and systematization of saṅgati within Navya-Nyāya — grounding it in the causal-cognitive framework of Nyāya epistemology — represents another instance of inter-school engagement and appropriation.

## 9. Raghunātha Śiromaṇi as Interpreter and Innovator

The papers (Miyasaka, Wada 2013, Wada 2014) engage with Raghunātha Śiromaṇi, Gaṅgeśa's most important successor. Reading these papers together illuminates Raghunātha's method of philosophical commentary.

In the vyāpti domain, Raghunātha's two rephrased definitions represent progressively more refined responses to edge cases that Gaṅgeśa's original definition cannot handle without further qualification. The first rephrasing addresses cases where the probans locus has no possibility of possessing anything by the delimiting relation of the probandumness (e.g., jātimān meyatvāt). The second rephrasing addresses cases where everything exists in the locus of the probans by the delimiting relation (e.g., ghaṭavān mahākālatvāt). Raghunātha's innovations — the concept of the two-fold absence (ubhayābhāva) and the specification of the delimiting relation within the absential counterpositiveness — do not change Gaṅgeśa's basic structural scheme but make it robust against an expanding range of cases.

In the linguistic domain, Wada's papers document that Raghunātha's discussions of verbal suffixes elaborate Gaṅgeśa's positions without fundamentally revising them. The concept of objectness (karmatva), which Gaṅgeśa introduces as the meaning of the verbal suffix in passive voice, is

given a precise elaboration in later Navya-Nyāya texts in terms that parallel Gaṅgeśa's vyāpti apparatus.

This pattern — Raghunātha elaborating Gaṅgeśa's framework through increasingly precise use of the same technical vocabulary — suggests that the Navya-Nyāya tradition is best understood not as a series of independent philosophical positions but as a cumulative research program in which each generation identifies edge cases and refines the technical apparatus to handle them, without abandoning the core ontological and epistemological commitments.

## 10. Methodological Reflections: Diagram, Translation, and Analysis

The papers employ strikingly different methodological approaches, and comparing these approaches is itself instructive.

Wada's papers are primarily translations with detailed annotation. The annotation explains technical terms, identifies the school affiliations of positions, provides the Sanskrit text in footnotes, and traces cross-references within and beyond the TC. This method is suited to the linguistic domain, where meaning is inseparable from the precise grammatical and semantic context of each term. Wada's synthetic 2014 paper adds a higher-level analytical layer, reconstructing Gaṅgeśa's full theory from across the TC by collecting views that Gaṅgeśa does not refute.

Miyasaka's paper is primarily structural and diagrammatic. The diagram method — representing qualificative cognitions as boxes connected by lines, with arrows for delimitation and dotted lines for absence-counterpositive relations — provides a visual representation of the logical structure that is genuinely illuminating. The diagrams make it possible to see at a glance why Gaṅgeśa's definition avoids over-application for invalid inferences and under-application for valid ones, and why Raghunātha's rephrasing is needed for edge cases. This method is suited to the logical domain, where the formal relations between entities can be represented spatially.

Shaw's paper is primarily analytical-philosophical. It reconstructs Gaṅgeśa's definitions of six types of saṅgati in terms that are accessible to philosophers trained in Western epistemology and logic, using formal-style definitions and examples drawn from the TC's own examples as well as from general epistemological contexts. This method is suited to the pragmatic-philosophical domain, where the conceptual analysis of relevance can be illuminated by comparison with Western theories of relevance and discourse coherence.

Each method has its advantages and its limitations. The translation method risks obscuring the systematic connections between different parts of the TC by presenting them sequentially and independently. The diagrammatic method risks imposing a visual representation that may not be faithful to the Navya-Nyāya understanding of the relations involved. The analytical method risks assimilating Navya-Nyāya concepts to Western frameworks in ways that distort their original meaning and context.

Reading the papers together mitigates these risks. The translation method's close attention to context enriches the diagrammatic method's structural analysis; the structural analysis illuminates connections that the translation method presents in isolation; and the analytical-philosophical method provides the conceptual framework within which both the translations and the diagrams can be interpreted.

## 11. Mithila as Intellectual Center

A contextual observation that emerges from these papers is the intellectual geography of Navya-Nyāya. Gaṅgeśa worked in Mithila (historically covering parts of present-day Bihar and Nepal), as did many of his successors including Raghunātha Śiromaṇi's teacher Sārvabhauma and Raghunātha himself. Wada's papers note that the scholarly tradition of studying Gaṅgeśa's TC has been sustained from its Mithila origins through later Navya-Nyāya centers and into modern scholarship in Japan (Nagoya University), New Zealand (Victoria University of Wellington), and internationally. The papers examined here represent contributions from scholars working in this global conversation about

a Maithili intellectual tradition — a tradition that Videha's own editorial work continues to preserve and disseminate in the Maithili language context.

## 12. Conclusion

Reading these papers together reveals Gaṅgeśa's Tattvacintāmaṇi as a unified philosophical project, not a collection of independent technical treatises. The same ontological commitments — thoroughgoing realism, the primacy of real relations over linguistic or logical conventions, the analysis of cognition as a structured event with real worldly content — underlie the philosophy of language, the logic of inference, and the pragmatics of philosophical inquiry. The same technical apparatus — avacchedaka, pratiyogitā, sāmānādhikaraṇya, viśeṣaṇa-viśeṣya — structures the analyses across all three domains, not as borrowed terminology but as genuine conceptual instruments serving the same epistemological purposes.

The avacchedaka emerges as the most pervasive and powerful of these concepts. It functions as a precision mechanism in the logical domain (preventing the sifting problem in vyāpti), in the semantic domain of verbal roots (specifying which universal delimits the causal state denoted by the root), in the semantic domain of verbal suffixes (grounding the reconceived coreferentiality in a specified number-property), and implicitly in the pragmatic domain of saṅgati (specifying which type of real relation constitutes the relevant kind of relevance).

Gaṅgeśa's achievement, as these papers collectively illuminate, is not only to have developed rigorous technical solutions to specific problems in logic and language. It is to have constructed a comprehensive framework in which logic, language, and inquiry are all understood as different dimensions of the same fundamental project: the systematic analysis of how the human mind grasps a structured, real world, and how language both tracks and is tracked by that world.

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Raghunātha Śiromaṇi. Siddhāntalakṣaṇa. In Tattvacintāmaṇi-dīdhiti-prakāśa of Bhavānanda Siddhāntavāgīśa. Edited by G. C. Tarkādarśanātīrtha. Bibliotheca Indica 194. Calcutta, 1910–12.

## ADDENDUM 4: WESTERN AND EAST ASIAN GANGESA UPADHYAYA SCHOLARS

Tattvacintāmaṇi as Viewed by Western, and Japanese Philosophers

……..

Gaṅgeśa solidified the "New" (navya) phase of the long-running school of epistemology and metaphysics known as Nyāya.

Western Philosophers and the Tattvacintāmaṇi

A. Daniel H. H. Ingalls — The Pioneer (Harvard, 1951)

The first serious Western scholarly engagement with Gaṅgeśa's text came through Ingalls. In his 1955 essay "Logic in India," Ingalls isolated three main innovations of Navya-Nyāya with respect to the earlier Nyāya school: "a new method of universalization, rendered possible by the concept of limitation (avacchedakatā); the discovery of a number of laws similar to the theorems of propositional logic; a new interest in the definition of relations and the use of these relations in operations of considerable complexity." These were identified as formal innovations, with Ingalls noting their proximity to developments in mathematical logic — a bold gesture in 1951.

Ingalls's work built on direct study in Calcutta under the Mahāmahopādhyāya Kālipada Tarkāchārya, representing the tradition of Harvard Oriental scholarship that took the TC seriously as a philosophical, not merely philological, document.

Daniel H.H. Ingalls (Materials for the Study of Navya-Nyāya Logic, 1951) opened Navya-Nyāya to English-language readers, identifying three key innovations: a new method of universalization through avacchedakatā (limitation); the discovery of laws analogous to theorems of propositional logic; and a new interest in defining relations and using them in complex operations.

B. The Frege-Russell-Navya-Nyāya Comparison

The most dramatic Western parallel drawn in the reception literature is between the Navya-Nyāya movement initiated by Gaṅgeśa and the revolution in symbolic logic in the West. The literature of Navya-Nyāya is described as a movement comparable in its implications to the burgeoning of symbolic logic and its concomitant philosophical speculations found in the writings of Frege, Russell, and Wittgenstein in the West at the end of the 19th and beginning of the 20th centuries.

This is a striking comparison worth unpacking. What Gaṅgeśa did for vyāpti (pervasion, the inference-warranting relation) — rigorously delimiting definitions, exposing the inadequacy of successive formulations through counter-examples, building a metalanguage precise enough to avoid ambiguity — is structurally parallel to what Frege did for the foundations of arithmetic and predicate logic. Frege unified the two strains of ancient logic — Aristotelian and Stoic — allowing for a much greater range of sentences to be parsed into logical form; one of his stated purposes was to isolate genuinely logical principles of inference. Gaṅgeśa's project in the Anumānakhaṇḍa (Inference chapter) was similarly to isolate the precise logical structure of the vyāpti relation, examining and discarding 21 successive definitions.

The comparison is not identity — Gaṅgeśa worked within a realist metaphysical framework (Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika ontology) and had no interest in logicism or set theory. But the methodological spirit — precision, definitional rigor, identification of logical form beneath natural-language appearance — is genuinely analogous.

C. Stephen H. Phillips — Systematic Western Engagement (2004)

Phillips and Tatacharya's Epistemology of Perception (2004), translating the Pratyakṣakhaṇḍa (Perception Chapter) of the Tattvacintāmaṇi, includes an

introduction covering essential theoretical and historical background, and a comparison of Nyāya with Western epistemological traditions.

Phillips's project represents the most sustained Western philosophical engagement with the TC at the level of detailed argument. He shows how Gaṅgeśa's epistemology of perception — with its distinction between nirvikalpaka (non-qualificative) and savikalpaka (qualificative) perception, its theory of sannnikarṣa (sense-object contact), and its realist account of universals — enters into genuine dialogue with questions in Western philosophy from Aristotle and Locke to Russell and Quine.

D. Bimal Krishna Matilal — The "Matilal Strategy" (Oxford)

Bimal Krishna Matilal (1935–1991) was an eminent philosopher whose writings presented the Indian philosophical tradition as a comprehensive system of logic incorporating most issues addressed by themes in Western philosophy. From 1977 to 1991, he served as the Spalding Professor of Eastern Religion and Ethics at the University of Oxford.

Matilal articulated his comparative motivation clearly: "Both contemporary analytical philosophy and the classical Nyāya and Buddhist tradition of India seem to be interested in the problems of knowledge and perception, the varieties of meaning and reference, the theory of inference, and the issue of psychologism." He was explicit that the gesture of comparison was needed to correct persistent misconceptions — "Too often the 'soft-mindedness' and tender nature of Indian 'philosophy' or Oriental wisdom have been emphasized. Too often the term 'Indian philosophy' is identified with a subject that is presented as mystical and non-argumentative."

Matilal was in conversation with philosophers in Oxford, most notably Peter Strawson, Michael Dummett, and Richard Sorabji, and was keenly interested in all questions philosophical and in how they could be addressed using resources from multiple philosophical traditions.

His key works bearing on Gaṅgeśa include:

• The Navya-Nyāya Doctrine of Negation (Harvard, 1968) — an analysis of the TC's treatment of abhāva (absence) in the framework of Western logic

• Epistemology, Logic and Grammar in Indian Philosophical Analysis (Mouton, 1971)

• Perception: An Essay on Classical Indian Theories of Knowledge (Oxford, 1986) — a sustained defence of Nyāya direct realism against Buddhist phenomenalism and Western sense-data theories

The Perception volume defends a form of realism known as Naïve Realism or Direct Realism — Nyāya Realism — reconstructing Nyāya arguments to meet objections from both the Buddhists and the sense-data representationalists. In doing so, Matilal brings Gaṅgeśa into explicit dialogue with Kant, Husserl, Russell, and the British empiricist tradition.

E. Karl H. Potter and the Encyclopedia of Indian Philosophies

The Encyclopedia of Indian Philosophies (Vol. VI), edited by Karl H. Potter and Sibajiban Bhattacharyya, begins with the most exhaustive account of the Tattvacintāmaṇi's contents hitherto available — some 300 pages compiled by over a dozen different summarizers — and reconstructs the development of Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika through the two centuries following Gaṅgeśa. This project treats the TC as deserving the same encyclopedic scholarly attention as any canonical Western philosophical text.

III. Japanese Philosophers and the Tattvacintāmaṇi

Japan has produced one of the most sustained and technically rigorous non-Indian scholarly traditions in Navya-Nyāya, centered at Nagoya University under Toshihiro Wada.

A. Toshihiro Wada (Nagoya University)

Wada obtained a Ph.D. from the University of Poona (1998) and a D.Litt. from Nagoya University (2002), and mainly works on logic and philosophy of language in Navya-Nyāya. He published Invariable Concomitance in Navya-Nyāya (1990) and The Analytical Method of Navya-Nyāya (2007), with papers appearing in the Journal of Indian Philosophy, Asiatische Studien, and Acta Asiatica.

Wada's approach is distinctive for combining traditional Sanskrit philology with the tools of formal logic and visual diagrammatics. His Analytical Method employs 86 diagrams based on the dharma-dharmin (property and property-possessor) relation as a visual aid to explain the structure of Navya-Nyāya analysis. He works primarily on Gaṅgeśa's Tattvacintāmaṇi and Mathurānātha's Tattvacintāmaṇi-rahasya, covering the Vyāpti-pañcaka (Five Definitions of Invariable Concomitance) section.

In his Navya-Nyāya Philosophy of Language, Wada analyzes the "Verbal Suffix Chapter" (Ākhyātavāda) of Gaṅgeśa's Tattvacintāmaṇi, clarifying Gaṅgeśa's view of the meaning of verbal suffixes — a matter disputed among Navya-Naiyāyikas, Mīmāṃsakas, and Grammarians — and investigates how

Gaṅgeśa determines the meaning of words, illustrating that his method bears upon the ontological categories of Vaiśeṣika. He explains the realistic standpoint of Navya-Nyāya by clarifying the concept of the counterpositive (pratiyogin) of absence (abhāva), focusing on empty terms such as "a round triangle," "the present King of France," and "a rabbit's horn."

This last point is philosophically remarkable: the Navya-Nyāya treatment of empty terms directly parallels Bertrand Russell's On Denoting (1905) — the problem of reference for non-existent objects. Wada makes this connection explicit, showing that Gaṅgeśa and Raghunātha Śiromaṇi already explored the logical consequences of "rabbit's horn" (śaśaviṣāṇa) as an empty term within a realist ontology.

B. The Nagoya University COE Programme

In 2002, the Graduate School of Letters at Nagoya University received a five-year national grant to establish an International Centre of Excellence in the humanities, focusing on Indian philosophy and text science. This produced a significant collaborative volume — Indian Philosophy and Text Science — in which Wada's chapter analyzed the genesis of Sanskrit texts in Navya-Nyāya, taking the Vyāpti-pañcaka section of the TC and its commentaries as a case study.

V. Structural Comparison: Key Philosophical Parallels

| Gaṅgeśa / TC Concept | Western Parallel | Japanese Reception |

|||||

| Vyāpti (invariable concomitance) | Aristotle's universal affirmation; Russell on propositional functions | Buddhist apoha (difference-based cognition) via Dignāga | Wada's formal diagrammatics of vyāpti |

| Pratyakṣa (direct perception) | Locke's simple ideas; Russell's knowledge by acquaintance | Xuanzang's vijñaptimātratā (representation-only) — contrasting position | Phillips-Wada crossover on perception realism |

|Avacchedakatā (delimitor/limitation) | Frege's concept-script quantification; Russell's Principia | Wada's diagrammatic formalisation |

| Empty terms (śaśaviṣāṇa) | Russell's "present King of France"; Frege on empty names | Daoist wu (non-being) — very different framework | Wada explicitly draws the Russell comparison |

| Pramāṇa pluralism (4 sources) | Cartesian rationalism vs. British empiricism | Confucian gé wù (investigation of things) | Inherited through Nakamura's comparative work |

Key Scholarly Works for Further Study

• Ingalls — Materials for the Study of Navya-Nyāya Logic (Harvard, 1951)

• Matilal — The Navya-Nyāya Doctrine of Negation (Harvard, 1968); Perception (Oxford, 1986)

• Phillips & Tatacharya — Epistemology of Perception: Gaṅgeśa's Tattvacintāmaṇi (AIBS, 2004)

• Potter & Bhattacharyya — Encyclopedia of Indian Philosophies, Vol. VI (Motilal Banarsidass, 1993)

• Wada — Invariable Concomitance in Navya-Nyāya (1990); The Analytical Method of Navya-Nyāya (2007); Navya-Nyāya Philosophy of Language (2020)

• Nakamura — Ways of Thinking of Eastern Peoples (U. Hawaii, 1964); A Comparative History of Ideas (Motilal, 1992)

| Ingalls, D.H.H. | Materials for the Study of Navya-Nyāya Logic (Harvard) | 1951 | English | First Western formal analysis of TC's logical innovations |

| Bhattacharya, D. | History of Navya-Nyāya in Mithilā | 1958 | English | Definitive regional history; biographical data on Gaṅgeśa |

| Frauwallner, E. | Geschichte der indischen Philosophie | 1953–56 | German |

| Potter, K.H. | Bibliography of Indian Philosophies | 1970 | English

| Vidyābhūṣaṇa, S.C. | History of Indian Logic | 1921 | English  Chakravarti, P. | Works on Navya-Nyāya | various | English/Bengali |

Matilal's Navya-Nyāya Doctrine of Negation (Harvard, 1968) Epistemology, Logic and Grammar (Mouton, 1971) Perception (Oxford, 1986)

History of Science, Philosophy and Culture in Indian Civilization, particularly within the volumes dedicated to Logic, Navya-Nyaya, and Epistemology. [Editor D P Chattopadhyaya

Potter-Bhattacharyya Encyclopedia Vol. VI (1993) both postdate the volume. This makes Nakamura's 1973 survey a valuable snapshot of the state of Gaṅgeśa scholarship at a transitional moment.

Ways of Thinking of Eastern Peoples (University of Hawaii Press, 1964)

A Comparative History of Ideas (Motilal Banarsidass, 1992)

A History of Early Vedānta Philosophy, Parts I & II (Motilal Banarsidass, 1989/2004)

Bimal Krishna Matilal extended this work into semantics and ontology.

D. Bhattacharya's History of Navya-Nyāya in Mithilā (1958) remains the most comprehensive regional history, and provides the biographical data on Gaṅgeśa.

The Tattvacintāmaṇi is a treatise in Sanskrit authored by the 14th-century logician and philosopher Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (fl. c. 1325). The title translates as "A Thought-jewel of Truth." The treatise introduced a new era in the history of Indian logic. Satis Chandra Vidyābhūṣaṇa, in his authoritative “history of Indian logic”, divided the millennia-long history of Indian logic into three periods — Ancient (650 BCE–100 CE), Medieval (100–1200 CE), and Modern (from 900 CE) — and identified the Tattvacintāmaṇi as the standard work of the Modern period.

## ADDENDUM 5

## Israel and Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya

The fact that the logical tradition most analogous to Navya-Nyāya in the Israeli context, namely Talmudic logic, has developed entirely separately with no historical contact with the Mithilā school.

### III. The Talmudic Logic Tradition — Israel's Own Analytical Parallel

This is the tradition of **Talmudic logic** (*higgayon talmudi*), which has been the subject of intensive modern formalisation in Israeli and diaspora Jewish scholarship.

### A. The Talmudic Logic Project (Dov Gabbay, Bar-Ilan / King's College London)

The Talmudic Logic project, ongoing since 2008, presents logical analysis of Talmudic reasoning using modern logical tools. The project investigates principles of Talmudic Logic and publishes a series of books — one for each principle — beginning with systematic analysis of Talmudic inference rules. The first book shows that Talmudic reasoning can be presented as a systematic logical system basic to modern non-deductive reasoning, covering *Argumentum A Fortiori*, abduction, and analogy.

The second level of the project works in the opposite direction: formulating Talmudic concepts and argumentation in logical form and applying or

comparing these formulations to known systems in computer science, AI, philosophy, law, and logic itself.

This project — which has produced over thirteen volumes and expects twenty-five to thirty more — is the Israeli scholarly tradition most directly analogous in method and ambition to the Navya-Nyāya scholarship of Ingalls, Matilal, and Wada. The *qal va-ḥomer* (a fortiori inference), the *binyan av* (analogical extension), and the *gezera shava* (definitional equivalence) of Talmudic hermeneutics share structural territory with the *vyāpti* (pervasion), *upamāna* (comparison), and *śabda* (testimony) of Gaṅgeśa's *pramāṇa* system.

**B. Avi Sion — *Judaic Logic* (1995)**

Avi Sion's *Judaic Logic: A Formal Analysis of Biblical, Talmudic and Rabbinic Logic* (1995) engages in a formal analysis of Biblical, Talmudic and Rabbinic logic as an original inquiry into the forms of thought determining Jewish law and belief, from the impartial perspective of a logician. It attempts to honestly estimate the extent to which the logic employed within Judaism fits into the general norms and whether it has any contributions to make to them. Sion is particularly interested in the *qal va-ḥomer* (a fortiori reasoning), noting that the Tanakh contains far more instances of this than traditionally claimed.

Sion's work, though not produced from within a university, represents a serious attempt to do for Talmudic logic what Ingalls did for Navya-Nyāya: make it available to formal logical analysis and comparative study.

**C. The Structural Comparison: Navya-Nyāya and Talmudic Logic**

The parallel between the two traditions is structurally significant and has, to date, not been drawn by any Israeli scholar in print. The comparison would rest on the following structural homologies:

| Navya-Nyāya (Gaṅgeśa) | Talmudic Logic |
|---|---|
| *Vyāpti* — invariable pervasion, the inference-warranting relation | *Binyan av* — analogical extension from a legal precedent |
| *Upādhi* — inferential undercutting condition | *Pirka* — Talmudic rebuttal; a condition that undermines a *kal va-ḥomer* |
| *Pakṣa, sādhya, hetu* — | *Niddon, melamed, limud* |

| Navya-Nyāya (Gaṅgeśa) | Talmudic Logic |
|---|---|
| subject, probandum, probans | — case, precedent, derived rule |
| *Avacchedakatā* — delimiting the range of a property | *Gezera shava* — definitional equivalence limiting the scope of a rule |
| *Śabdakhaṇḍa* — the epistemology of testimony | Talmudic *mesirah*, *shmuah*, *kabalah* — the epistemology of oral transmission |
| Technical metalanguage in Sanskrit, avoiding natural-language ambiguity | Aramaic legal metalanguage (*lashon* distinctions) avoiding ambiguity in halakhic derivation |

Both traditions developed rigorous technical languages within a natural-language base (Sanskrit and Aramaic respectively), both were concerned with the problem of when an inference is valid and when it is defeated, and both arose in religious-legal contexts where the stakes of logical precision were high. Gaṅgeśa's exhaustive examination and rejection of 21 successive definitions of *vyāpti* in the *Anumānakhaṇḍa* is structurally comparable to the Talmudic practice of raising and refuting (*kushiya ve-teshuvah*) successive interpretations of a legal principle.

**D. Why This Comparison Has Not Been Made**

The comparison has not been made by Israeli scholars for three reasons:

1. **No Sanskrit competence in the Talmudic logic tradition**: The Talmudic Logic project (Gabbay) and Sion's *Judaic Logic* both compare Talmudic logic to Western formal systems (Frege, non-monotonic logic, deontic logic, abduction theory) but not to Indian systems, because their authors do not have Sanskrit or Indological training.

2. **No Nyāya competence among Israeli Indologists**: The Israeli Indologist most equipped for such a comparison, Grinshpon, works on Vedānta and Yoga — not Nyāya. His orientation is phenomenological and hermeneutical, not formal-logical.

3. **Historical non-contact**: Unlike the Greek-Aristotelian logic tradition, which entered both Jewish (via Maimonides and medieval Jewish Aristotelianism) and Islamic thought, the Indian Nyāya tradition had no transmission route into Jewish intellectual culture. There was no historical contact between Mithilā and Babylonian or Jerusalem academies. The two traditions developed in complete mutual ignorance of each other — which makes a comparative study of their structural parallels all the more philosophically interesting.

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## IV. Medieval Jewish Philosophy and the Nyāya Theistic Argument

There is one indirect point of contact between the broader Nyāya tradition and Jewish philosophy: the **cosmological and teleological arguments for the existence of God**.

The Nyāya school, culminating in Udayana's *Nyāyakusumāñjali* (11th century) and carrying forward into Gaṅgeśa's framework, developed rigorous logical arguments for a world-creating God (*Īśvara*) — arguments that bear structural comparison to Maimonides' cosmological arguments in the *Guide for the Perplexed* (12th century). Both Udayana and Maimonides were responding to anti-theistic opponents (Buddhist nominalists and Aristotelian eternalists respectively) and both used inferential reasoning from the structured complexity of the world to a designing intelligence.

No Israeli scholar appears to have pursued this comparison in relation to the Nyāya tradition specifically — though it has been explored in the general context of comparative natural theology by scholars like Eleonore Stump (Catholic) and Alvin Plantinga (Reformed). For Israeli scholars of medieval Jewish philosophy at Bar-Ilan and Hebrew University, the Udayana-Maimonides comparison would be a natural entry into the broader Nyāya tradition, from which Gaṅgeśa inherits the theistic realism.

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## V. The Israel Institute for Advanced Studies — A Potential Venue

The Israel Institute for Advanced Studies (IIAS), established by the Hebrew University of Jerusalem in 1975, is a self-governing body whose mission is to create multidisciplinary learning communities of academics. The IIAS promotes excellence in collaborative and individual scholarship on compelling intellectual challenges and welcomes researchers and scholars from all fields

and from all parts of the world. It annually hosts six Advanced Schools as well as many conferences.

The IIAS has previously hosted research groups in comparative philosophy and history of science, and would be the natural venue for a collaborative research group bringing together Indian logicians (Nyāya specialists from India, the US, or Japan) with Israeli Talmudic logic scholars — the kind of structural comparison outlined above. Such a group has not, to date, been convened.

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### VI. Comparative Summary: Israel in the Global Reception Map

| **Region** | **Engagement with Gaṅgeśa** | **Key Route of Transmission** |
|---|---|---|
| USA/UK | High — Ingalls, Matilal, Phillips, Potter | Direct textual scholarship, analytic philosophy |
| Germany/Austria | Medium — Frauwallner, classical Indology | 19th-century Sanskrit philology tradition |
| Japan | High — Wada, Nakamura, Nagoya school | Indological Sanskrit training + comparative philosophy |
| Tibet | High — Gelug curriculum, *pramāṇa* studies | Buddhist epistemology (Dharmakīrti tradition) |
| China | Minimal — Buddhist *pramāṇa* only | Chinese Buddhism via Xuanzang |
| Korea | None identified | Same Buddhist channel as China; no Nyāya transmission |
| **Israel** | **None identified** | **No historical transmission route; own logical tradition (Talmudic) developed independently** |

### VII. Conclusion: The Unrealised Comparison

The Israeli absence from Gaṅgeśa scholarship is not, as in some other cases, a simple result of limited Indological infrastructure. Israel has a philosophy

department at Tel Aviv explicitly open to Eastern philosophy, an active Indologist at Hebrew University, and one of the world's richest indigenous logical traditions in Talmudic analysis. What is missing is the specific bridge: a scholar with both Sanskrit competence in the Nyāya tradition and knowledge of the Talmudic analytical method deep enough to place Gaṅgeśa in productive comparative dialogue with the Babylonian academies.

That comparison — between the *Tattvacintāmaṇi*'s rigorous definitional method and the Talmud's *kushiya ve-teshuvah* dialectic; between Gaṅgeśa's *vyāpti* and the Talmudic *binyan av*; between Navya-Nyāya's technical Sanskrit metalanguage and halakhic Aramaic precision — is one of the genuinely unexplored comparative-philosophical territories of our time. For *Videha*'s tradition, which is rooted in Mithilā — the very geography that produced Gaṅgeśa — making this comparison visible to the world is a task of genuine cultural and intellectual importance.

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**Key Israeli Institutions for Future Research on This Topic:**

Department of Indian Studies / Comparative Religion, Hebrew University (Yohanan Grinshpon)

Department of Philosophy, Tel Aviv University (Eastern philosophy programme)

Israel Institute for Advanced Studies, Hebrew University (potential collaborative venue)

Department of Jewish Philosophy, Bar-Ilan University (Talmudic logic specialists)

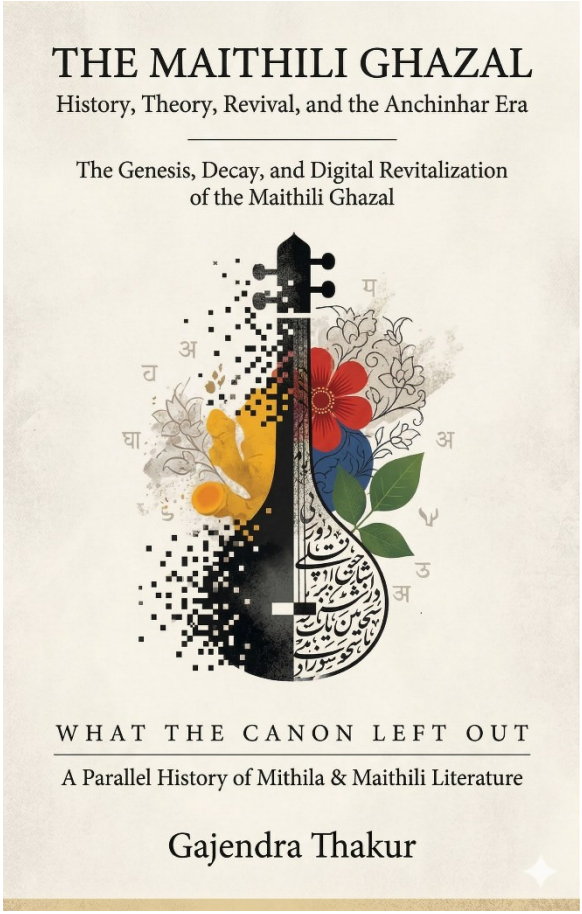
The Talmudic Logic Project publications (Gabbay series, College Publications London) — for structural comparison with Navya-Nyāya

Ben-Ami Scharfstein (1919–2019) was a remarkably versatile Israeli-American philosopher and scholar, best known for his "philosophy without borders." He spent much of his career as a professor at Tel Aviv University, where he was a founding member of the Department of Philosophy.

What made Scharfstein stand out was his refusal to stick to the Western "canon." He was a pioneer in comparative philosophy, arguing that Indian and Chinese traditions were just as analytically rigorous and significant as those in Europe.

In his seminal work, A Comparative History of World Philosophy: From the Upanishads to Kant (1998), Ben-Ami Scharfstein places Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (the 14th-century founder of Navya-Nyāya) in a unique global context. He categorizes Gaṅgeśa's philosophy as "Logic-Sensitized, Methodological Metaphysics," grouping him alongside Western giants like Descartes and Leibniz.Scharfstein's analysis centers on several key themes:1. The Methodological ParallelScharfstein argues that Gaṅgeśa represents a "modern" turn in Indian philosophy, much like Descartes did for the West. He notes that while Gaṅgeśa remained ontologically conservative—keeping the traditional Nyāya-Vaiśeṣika categories—his method was revolutionary. By prioritizing the precision of language and the definition of terms, Gaṅgeśa moved philosophy away from speculative metaphysics and toward a rigorous, logic-centered inquiry.2. Response to SkepticismA central point for Scharfstein is Gaṅgeśa's defense of realism against the "fideistic neo-skepticism" of thinkers like Śrīharṣa. Scharfstein observes that Gaṅgeśa did not simply ignore the skeptics; he developed an incredibly sophisticated technical language to define "knowledge" and "invariable concomitance" ($vyāpti$) so precisely that the skeptics' verbal traps could no longer function.3. Comparison with Descartes and LeibnizScharfstein draws a fascinating comparison between these three thinkers:Descartes: Like Descartes, Gaṅgeśa sought an indubitable foundation for knowledge, though Gaṅgeśa found it in the causal reliability of the world rather than the "Cogito."Leibniz: Scharfstein sees a resemblance between Gaṅgeśa's technical Navya-Nyāya language and Leibniz's dream of a characteristica universalis (a universal logical language). Both believed that if we could define our concepts with enough precision, philosophical disputes could be resolved through "calculation" or formal analysis.4. Epistemological RealismScharfstein highlights Gaṅgeśa's "super-reliabilism." He explains that for Gaṅgeśa, knowledge is not just a belief that happens to be true, but a state of awareness generated by a reliable causal process. Scharfstein points out that Gaṅgeśa's focus on the Tattvacintāmaṇi (The Thought-Jewel of Reality) was to prove that the world is knowable and that our logical instruments ($pramāṇas$) are robust.Summary of Scharfstein's ViewScharfstein admires Gaṅgeśa for his unprecedented clarity and intellectual honesty. He views Navya-Nyāya not as a "dead" scholasticism, but as a peak of human analytical achievement that reached a level of formal sophistication that the West did not match until the late 19th or early 20th century.

**LESSON 003 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**




# THE MAITHILI GHAZAL

*History, Theory, Revival, and the Anchinhar Era*

*The Genesis, Decay, and Digital Revitalization of the Maithili Ghazal*

## Preface

This chapter covers: the Arabic and Persian genealogy of the ghazal form; its journey through Urdu into Maithili; the lineage of correct practice from Pandit Jivan Jha through the Anchinhar era; the specific rupture of the "dark interlude"

of grammatically incorrect ghazal writing and the erasure of legitimate poets; the theoretical foundations of Ghazalsastram; the formal architecture of the Maithili ghazal in technical detail; the Anchinhar Aakhar movement's revitalisation programme and digital democratisation strategy; the construction of new Maithili Bahars; the expansion of the genre into Bal (Children's) and Bhakti (Devotional) sub-forms; the structural reconvergence of ghazal with Maithili drama in 2026; the role of Wikipedia in archival preservation; the institutional context of the Videha Parallel Literature Movement; the relationship between formal prosody and democratic anti-caste poetics; and a comparative analysis of the Maithili case against other Indian regional-language ghazal movements.

The chapter, wherever possible, the formal conventions of the ghazal - bahr, qafiya, radif, matla, maqta, sher - are explained in concrete technical terms, so that the chapter may function not merely as a literary history but as an accessible introduction to the prosodic knowledge that the Anchinhar movement has striven to democratise.

## Summary

This chapter documents the 500-year journey of the Ghazal form into Maithili, identifying a critical rupture in the late twentieth century when grammatical rigour (Behr and Qaafiyaa) was abandoned, leading to a "weak era" of the form. It documents the corrective Anchinhar Aakhar (Unfamiliar Word) movement, the creation of the first theoretical manual (Ghajalsastram), and the expansion of the genre into Bal (Children's) and Bhakti (Devotional) Ghazals. The Maithili Ghazal has undergone a structural reconvergence with drama (2026) and achieved digital democratisation via Wikipedia, establishing itself as a parallel literary history against caste-based exclusion.

Key findings of this chapter:

- The Maithili ghazal has a documented correct lineage from Pandit Jivan Jha (early 20th century) through Kavivara Sitaram Jha, Kashikant Mishra 'Madhup', Vijaynath Jha, and Yoganand Heera.
- A "dark interlude" of grammatically incorrect ghazal writing erased Vijaynath Jha and Yoganand Heera from literary history; their restoration is a structural act of literary justice.
- The Anchinhar Aakhar movement, launched on April 11, 2008, restored formal standards through the Ghajalsastram - the first comprehensive Maithili-language theoretical account of the ghazal. It brought 350 to 400

new and previously marginalised writers into the literary mainstream within a single decade.

- Gajendra Thakur, recognised as Maithili's first "Aruji" (scholar of ghazal prosody), authored the first Ghajalsastram. Ashish Anchinhar published Maithili Ghazalak Vyakarana o Itihasa (Grammar and History of Maithili Ghazal), providing the systematic theoretical framework.
- Ashish Anchinhar is credited with constructing new Bahars specific to Maithili phonetics, expanding the genre into Bal and Bhakti sub-forms, and the reconvergence of ghazal with drama (2026).
- The digital-first strategy - blog, Wikipedia, online mushaira - has democratised access to formal ghazal knowledge, bypassing caste-based institutional gatekeeping.
- RTI data compiled by Vinit Utpal and Ashish Anchinhar (2011–2014) reveals that the Sahitya Akademi excluded women, effectively silencing their contribution to the literary canon. The Anchinhar Aakhar movement acted against this by giving precedence to women in award citations.

# Part I: A Brief History of the Ghazal - Arabia to Mithila

## 1.1 The Nasib, the Qasida, and the Birth of the Ghazal (7th–8th Century CE)

The ghazal emerged in Arabia during the seventh century CE not as a new invention but as an act of poetic surgery. The pre-Islamic qasida - the long ode of the desert tribes - had always begun with a nostalgic, amorous overture called the nasib: a lament for the abandoned campsite, the vanished beloved, the receding youth. Poets and audiences both recognised this opening passage as the most emotionally charged section of the qasida, more immediate and personal than the praise-sections or boast-sections that followed. Gradually, poets began composing the nasib alone, stripped from its context in the longer ode and given an independent existence.

The Arabic word ghazal (غزل) is thought to derive from a root associated with the act of spinning yarn or thread - a metaphor for the weaving of words - and has also been interpreted as the sound of a dying gazelle, an image consonant with the form's characteristic register of pain, longing, and martyrdom-in-love. The earliest Arabic ghazal poets include Jamil ibn Ma'mar of the Banu Udhra tribe, who gave his name to the "Udhri" tradition of chaste, self-sacrificial love:

loving unto death, with no expectation of physical consummation. The opposing tradition - urban, worldly, playful, and erotic - was exemplified by 'Umar ibn Abi Rabi'ah of the Quraysh (d. c. 712 CE), who treated love as pleasurable social comedy rather than metaphysical catastrophe.

These two poles - Udhri asceticism and Hejazi worldliness - established the emotional range within which all subsequent ghazal poetry would operate. The Sufi tradition, which came to dominate the Persian ghazal, is in some sense a synthesis of both poles: it takes the self-annihilating devotion of Udhri love and applies it to the divine, while retaining the sensuous imagery of the Hejazi tradition as a language of earthly metaphor for transcendent experience.

## 1.2 Persia: Rumi, Hafiz, and the Sufi Ghazal (10th–14th Century)

When the ghazal reached Persia in the wake of the Arab conquests - carried by cultural exchange, diplomatic contact, and the personal movement of poets between courts - it found a soil extraordinarily hospitable to its growth. Persian literary culture had its own rich tradition of love poetry, and the synthesis of Arabic prosodic rigour with Persian lyric sensibility produced, within two centuries, a ghazal tradition of unrivalled depth and sophistication.

Sana'i of Ghazna (d. c. 1131 CE) was the first major Persian poet to use the ghazal systematically as a vehicle for Sufi spiritual teaching. His successor 'Attar deepened this vein. But it was Jalal ud-Din Rumi (1207–1273) who made the ghazal into a vehicle of ecstatic mysticism - his Divan-i Shams-i Tabrizi contains approximately 3,500 ghazals, composed often in states of spiritual intoxication, the poem becoming itself an enactment of the longing it described. Rumi's ghazals typically end not with a takhallus (pen name) but with a sudden turn or silence - a formal enactment of the mystic's inability to speak the inexpressible.

Sa'di Shirazi (d. 1291) formalised and classicised the ghazal, establishing the convention of the takhallus in the maqta (final couplet) and developing a tone of elegant, worldly wisdom. He was among the first to write ghazals of consistent technical perfection in all their formal elements simultaneously: a musical bahr, a clear and consistent qafiya, an appropriate radif, a doubled matla, and a takhallus-bearing maqta.

Hafiz Shirazi (c. 1315–1390) represents the apex of the Persian ghazal tradition. His collected Divan has been among the most-printed books in the history of Islamic civilisation, and his ghazals are still used for divination (fal-e

Hafiz) in Iran today. Hafiz perfected the art of iham - the deliberate double meaning in which every word carries simultaneously an earthly and a Sufi spiritual interpretation. A line apparently about wine and the beloved could equally be read as an account of divine intoxication and the soul's union with God. This ambiguity was not a weakness but the form's greatest strength: it allowed the ghazal to speak simultaneously to the uninitiated lover and the Sufi adept, the courtier and the mystic, the lover of beauty and the seeker of truth.

The formal features of the Persian ghazal that passed into Urdu and eventually Maithili are: the mono-rhyme (qafiya) appearing at the end of the second line of every sher; the radif (identical refrain word or phrase) following the qafiya; the matla in which both lines carry qafiya and radif; the self-contained, independent sher as the fundamental unit of composition; and the takhallus in the maqta. These conventions, developed over three centuries of Persian ghazal writing, arrived in India structurally intact.

## 1.3 The Sufi Route to India: Amir Khusrau and the Vernacular Turn (12th–13th Century)

The ghazal's arrival in the Indian subcontinent was not primarily a courtly event but a spiritual one. The great Chishti Sufi masters - Mu'inuddin Chishti at Ajmer, Nizamuddin Auliya at Delhi, Qutbuddin Bakhtiyar Kaki - established hospices (dargahs) that became centres of vernacular musical culture. The sama (spiritual listening) sessions held at these dargahs used Persian and increasingly Hindavi (the nascent vernacular of north India) ghazals as vehicles of devotional transport.

Amir Khusrau (1253–1325), court poet of several Delhi sultans and most intimately associated with Nizamuddin Auliya, stands at the junction of Persian literary tradition and Indian vernacular innovation. His bilingual compositions - sometimes Persian above, Hindavi below - are among the earliest examples of the ghazal in an Indian vernacular. He is credited with such innovations as the khayal form in music, the qawwali, and the ghazal in Hindavi. In doing so, he established the template for all subsequent Indian-language ghazal writing: the structural conventions of the Persian ghazal transplanted into an indigenous linguistic and musical context.

The Deccan Sultanates - Bidar, Golconda, Bijapur - became the next major site of ghazal development. Muhammad Quli Qutb Shah (1565–1611), Sultan of Golconda, composed ghazals in what scholars call Dakhni Urdu - a southern variety of the emerging vernacular, rich in Telugu, Marathi, and Kannada

loanwords. The Dakhni tradition established the ghazal as the prestige lyric form of the Urdu-medium literary world.

The decisive turning point for the Urdu ghazal in northern India came around 1700, when Wali Muhammad Wali Dakkani visited Delhi. His divan of Hindavi/Rekhta ghazals - technically accomplished, emotionally sophisticated, and available in the vernacular that Delhi's poets had been trained to look down upon - electrified the city's literary establishment. Within a generation, Delhi's Persian-trained poets had redirected their energies into Urdu ghazal composition, setting the stage for the golden age of the eighteenth century.

## 1.4 The Golden Age of Urdu Ghazal: From Mir to Ghalib (18th–19th Century)

The eighteenth century saw the Urdu ghazal reach a peak of formal sophistication and emotional range that has never been surpassed. Mir Taqi Mir (1722–1810), who experienced the sack of Delhi in 1739 by Nadir Shah and again by Ahmad Shah Durrani in 1757, wrote ghazals of extraordinary immediacy and intimacy - often in a simple, almost conversational idiom that somehow carried immense emotional weight. He is known as "Khuda-e Suk'han" (God of Poetry) in the Urdu tradition, and his couplets have become proverbs in the sub-continental literary imagination.

The Lucknow school - associated with poets such as Insha, Jurrat, Atish, and Nasikh - developed a more ornate, technically fastidious style in contrast to Delhi's emotionally direct manner. Lucknow poets were connoisseurs of verbal felicity, grammatical precision, and the pleasures of the mazmun (conceits): elaborate metaphysical comparisons that demonstrated the poet's ingenuity. The tension between Delhi's emotional directness and Lucknow's technical virtuosity has been a productive fault-line in Urdu ghazal writing ever since.

Mirza Ghalib (1797–1869) transcends this binary. Writing in the twilight of the Mughal Empire - he witnessed the catastrophic events of 1857 from within Delhi - Ghalib pushed the ghazal to its philosophical limit. His poetry is famous for its difficulty: multiple simultaneous interpretations, grammatically ambiguous constructions, philosophical paradoxes folded into a single sher. Ghalib wrote of God, death, wine, love, and the ache of consciousness itself - and treated all these subjects with a complex, rueful irony that makes his work inexhaustible. His letters, written in Urdu prose, are as celebrated as his poetry; together they constitute one of the richest individual literary personalities in any South Asian language.

After Ghalib, the Urdu ghazal democratised. The mushaira - the public poetry recital - became an institution in which poets of all backgrounds competed for audience approval with technically accomplished, emotionally accessible ghazals. Daag Dehlvi (1831–1905) was the great populariser of this era: his ghazals were melodious, clear, emotionally immediate, and ideally suited to musical performance. The twentieth century saw the ghazal enter the gramophone and radio age: Begum Akhtar, Mehdi Hassan, Ghulam Ali, and Jagjit Singh each built mass audiences for the form, transforming it from a literary into a popular cultural institution while largely preserving its classical formal requirements.

Faiz Ahmed Faiz (1911–1984) represents the convergence of the classical ghazal tradition with modern political consciousness: his ghazals use the classical vocabulary of love, separation, and longing as a transparent metaphor for political imprisonment, state violence, and revolutionary hope. His language moves between Persian high diction and accessible Urdu idiom with an ease that makes his ghazals simultaneously classical and modern, personal and political.

## 1.5 The Ghazal in Other Indian Languages: The Comparative Frame

Alongside its development in Urdu, the ghazal was being adapted - imperfectly at first, then with growing assurance - into several of India's regional languages. Each adaptation faced the same fundamental challenge: how to transplant a prosodic system derived from the quantitative metrics of Arabic-Persian into a language with a different phonological structure, different natural rhythms, and different literary traditions.

In Bengali, the ghazal arrived via the intellectual and cultural ferment of nineteenth-century Calcutta. Atul Prasad Sen (1871–1934) and Kazi Nazrul Islam (1899–1976) are the foundational Bengali ghazal poets. Nazrul, whose personal biography combined Muslim and Hindu cultural inheritance, was temperamentally suited to the ghazal's synthesis of erotic and spiritual themes. His Bengali ghazals maintain bahr discipline while deploying a Bengali diction and musical sensibility that makes them feel entirely native to the language. Shamsur Rahman and others continued the Bengali revival. The Bengal region's shared medieval Sultanate Persian influence - including the famous correspondence between Sultan Ghiyasuddin Azam Shah and Hafiz - meant the ghazal was not entirely foreign to the Bengali literary imagination even before Atul Prasad Sen formalised Bengali ghazal composition.

In Gujarati, the ghazal tradition spans approximately a century. The Saurashtra region and the literary circles of Ahmedabad produced a continuous succession of ghazal poets: Balashankar Kantharia, the romantic poet Kalapi (Surashatasinhji Takhtsinhji), Barkat Virani "Befaam", and the prodigiously prolific Asim Randeri. The Gujarati ghazal is closely tied to mushaira culture and to the Bohra and Khoja Muslim communities who maintained connections with Urdu literary tradition while composing in Gujarati.

In Marathi, Suresh Bhat (1932–2003) is the pivotal figure. Known as "Ghazal Samrat" (Emperor of Ghazals), Bhat encountered Urdu ghazals through self-study around 1955, and spent the remainder of his life demonstrating that the form could be written with full formal rigour in Marathi. His first collection Roopgandha (1961) included only seven ghazals among 72 poems; by Elgar (1983) and Jhanjhawat, ghazals dominated his output entirely. He published six major collections comprising 532 poems, approximately 260 of which were ghazals. Like a classical Ustad, he guided and corrected students, established a pedagogical lineage, and - crucially - maintained technical standards even as he expanded the form's thematic range to include social protest, Ambedkarite critique, and personal anguish. His conversion to Buddhism and explicit alignment with Ambedkarite thought places the Marathi ghazal within the tradition of counter-canonical, anti-caste literary activism - a parallel to the Maithili movement's democratic commitments. His best-known verses were set to music by Hridaynath Mangeshkar and sung by Lata Mangeshkar and Asha Bhosle, giving Marathi ghazal a mass cultural reach comparable to the recorded Urdu ghazal tradition.

In Hindi, Dushyant Kumar (1931–1975) performed an analogous though differently inflected role. Writing in the shadow of post-1857 Partition anxieties about the Hindi-Urdu divide, Dushyant used the ghazal as a vehicle for what he called "New Poetry" in the popular idiom: his collection Saaye Mein Dhoop (1975, published just before his death at 44) directed the classical ghazal's formal architecture toward political satire and social outrage. His line about even the shade of trees scorching became a defining image of post-independence disillusionment, widely quoted in political movements including the 2011 anti-corruption agitation. Dushyant had to navigate not merely the technical challenge of adapting Arabic-Persian prosody to Hindi phonology, but the ideological minefield of a literary tradition weaponised in partition violence. Adil Mansuri, Bashir Badr, and others developed the Hindi ghazal further.

In Telugu, the ghazal represents an even more radical linguistic transplant: from an Indo-Aryan prosodic tradition into a Dravidian language. Ghazal Srinivas pioneered Telugu ghazal writing, requiring substantial theoretical innovation to accommodate the quantitative bahr system to Telugu's agglutinative morphology and phonological patterns.

# Part II: The Maithili Ghazal - Classical Phase, Dark Interlude, and the Disrupted Lineage

## 2.1 The Emotional Soil: Vidyapati and Pre-Ghazal Sensibility

To understand the Maithili ghazal's arrival, one must understand the literary landscape into which it arrived - and the ideology that resisted it. Maithili's greatest poet, Pre-Jyotirishwar Vidyapati [different from Samskrit and Avahatta Vidyapati (c. 1352-1448)], had already established a lyric tradition of extraordinary emotional depth and formal sophistication long before the ghazal as a named form appeared in the language. Vidyapati's padavali - his collection of songs celebrating the love of Radha and Krishna - fused erotic shringara rasa with Vaishnava bhakti in ways that established a template for Maithili lyric consciousness that persists to the present.

Vidyapati's declaration "Desil bayana sab jan mittha" - "The language of the land is sweet to all" - was not merely a linguistic preference but a literary-political manifesto: the assertion that vernacular Maithili, not Sanskrit, was the appropriate vehicle for the deepest human and spiritual experience. This vernacular assertion has a structural parallel with the ghazal's own history: the form that began in Arabic was taken up by Persian Sufis as a vehicle for speaking truth in the living language, rather than the classical tongue.

Vidyapati's padavali explores the full emotional range of shringara rasa: sambhoga (joy of union), vipralambha (the pain of separation), viraha (the ache of absence). These are the emotional materials of the ghazal. The nayika waiting for her beloved, the poet who transforms personal suffering into art, the beloved who is simultaneously present in memory and absent in reality - this emotional triangle is as central to Vidyapati's world as to Hafiz's. When the ghazal arrived in Maithili, it found an audience already formed by six centuries of this lyric tradition; the emotional resonance was immediate and deep.

The nachari (devotional songs to Shiva) and Maheshvani traditions associated with Vidyapati and continued by later Maithili poets including Kashikant Mishra 'Madhup' add a further dimension of consonance: the devotional tradition of addressing a transcendent, sometimes absent divine beloved in the language of human longing maps naturally onto the Sufi ghazal's spiritual register. The Anchinhar movement argues that Vidyapati's emotional sensibility (sringar rasa) was a proto-ghazal feeling, waiting for the Persian structural

container. Thus, the Maithili Ghazal is not an import but a nativisation of an imported form.

The Maithili lyric's own tradition of the radif-like refrain - in which the closing word or phrase of each pada echoes across the song - creates a prosodic environment that is hospitable to the ghazal form's insistence on radif. Vidyapati's Bhanita practice (inserting the poet's name in the closing stanza) parallels the maqta convention. And the independence of individual sher within a ghazal - each couplet complete in itself, not requiring narrative continuity - resonates with the tradition of standalone lyric stanzas in the Padavali.

The resistance to the ghazal was also ideological. For much of the institutional Maithili literary establishment - centred on upper-caste Brahmin cultural organisations in Darbhanga and Sahitya Akademi circles - the ghazal was associated with Urdu and, by extension, with a Muslim cultural tradition that these custodians of the Sanskrit-inflected Maithili canon were reluctant to embrace. Yet the suppressed history of Maithili has always involved contact with Arabic and Persian elements: Jyotirishwar's Varnanaratnakara uses Arabic and Persian loanwords, the Muslim weavers' dialect (Jolahiboli) - the Maithili of Muslim weavers, heavily inflected with Arabic, Persian, and Urdu - had long provided a vernacular bridge between the ghazal's cultural world and the Maithili speech community. The Muslim population of Tirhut (particularly in Darbhanga, Saharsa, and Purnea) spoke this dialect, and the Ain-i-Akbari mentions the Nachari songs of Mithila - suggesting a centuries-old interface between the Persian-influenced Mughal court culture and the vernacular lyric traditions of Mithila. The formal revitalisation of the Maithili ghazal in the twenty-first century is therefore less a rupture than a recovery of a suppressed cross-cultural strand.

Maithili's lyric tradition - grounded in Vidyapati's Padavali, the Nachari, the Maheshvani, and the Samadauni - was so deeply rooted in Sanskrit prosody, Prakrit moraic metres, and devotional modes that the qafiya-radif structure of the ghazal appeared alien to the tradition's formal self-understanding. The Anchinhar Aakhar blog's section on ghazal forms in other Indian languages makes the counter-argument: that there are structural homologies between the Maithili lyric tradition and the ghazal form that make Maithili a particularly apt language for ghazal composition. The 'Anchinhar Aakhar' Ghazal movement has demonstrated that Maithili can handle the most complex Behr. The Maithili soil was, in multiple senses, already prepared.

## 2.2 The Golden Period: Pandit Jivan Jha and the Dramatic Debut

The Maithili Ghazal began correctly, adhering to the prosody of Behr (meter) and Qaafiyaa (rhyme scheme: AA, BA, CA...). The first documented Maithili ghazals were composed by Pandit Jivan Jha and incorporated into his play Sundar-Samyog (also rendered Sunder-Sanyog). This fact carries multiple layers of significance.

First: these were grammatically correct ghazals - observing bahr and qafiya in their proper classical senses. Pandit Jivan Jha had clearly absorbed the formal principles of the ghazal from the Urdu tradition and successfully applied them to Maithili. Second: the choice of a dramatic context for the ghazal's Maithili debut connects to a tradition reaching back through the Ankiya Naat and Kirtaniya dramatic forms of Mithila, which had themselves used lyric inserts - song-poems embedded within dramatic structure - as a primary vehicle of emotional expression.

This conjunction of ghazal and drama at the origin point of Maithili ghazal writing is not an accident. It reflects a deep structural affinity between the ghazal as a lyric form and the requirements of Maithili theatrical expression. The ghazal's self-contained shers, each a complete emotional unit, function naturally as a lyric insert within a larger dramatic structure. A character in emotional extremity can sing or recite a ghazal in which each sher expresses a different facet of her or his feeling; the independence of the shers allows for dramatic flexibility, and the repeated radif creates the music of obsessive emotion appropriate to dramatic climax. The Maithili ghazal thus began not as a printed lyric form but as a performed dramatic element, embedded in the living theatrical tradition of Mithila.

## 2.3 Kavivara Sitaram Jha and Kashikant Mishra "Madhup"

Following Pandit Jivan Jha, the classical phase of Maithili ghazal was carried forward by Kavivara Sitaram Jha (1891–1975) and Kashikant Mishra 'Madhup' (1906–1987). Both composed ghazals that were structurally sound - bahr and qafiya correctly observed. Kavivar Sitaram Jha was a distinguished scholar of Sanskrit and a master of the intricacies of *Chhanda Shastra* (prosody). While the influence of Madhup Ji is undeniable, Sitaram Jha expanded the horizon of the Maithili Gazal, surpassing his contemporaries through both prolific output and a remarkable diversity of thematic content. He occupies a seminal position in our literary history as the pioneer of the political Gazal; furthermore, his

contributions serve as the foundational wellspring for both children's poetry (*Baal*) and devotional (*Bhakti*) compositions within this specific form.

Kashikant Mishra 'Madhup' stands as one of the towering personalities of modern Maithili literature. His epic Radha-Viraha earned him the Sahitya Akademi Award in 1970 - the highest literary recognition in India. His nachari tradition maintained the devotional dimension of Maithili lyric inherited from Vidyapati, while his engagement with the ghazal form showed the same formal discipline. Madhup belonged to the generation of Maithili writers - along with Pt. Chandranath Mishra 'Amar', Harimohan Jha, Kanchinath Jha 'Kiran', and Surendra Jha 'Suman' - who collectively produced what is now recognised as the golden age of modern Maithili literature in the mid-twentieth century.

The significance of Madhup's engagement with the ghazal cannot be overstated: it gave the form the institutional prestige of association with the Akademi-winning mainstream of Maithili literary culture. When the ghazal was written by Madhup - a poet of his standing - it could not be dismissed as an Urdu import. It was part of the Maithili literary mainstream, demonstrating what a rigorous, formally disciplined Maithili ghazal could achieve.

## 2.4 The Correct Sequence of Maithili Ghazal Writers

Based on structural accuracy and chronological sequence, the legitimate lineage of Maithili ghazal writers - those who wrote with correct Behr and Qaafiyaa - is:

1. Pandit Jivan Jha (first experiment; dramatic debut in Sundar-Samyog)
2. Kavivar Sitaram Jha
3. Kashikant Mishra 'Madhup'
4. Vijaynath Jha
5. Yoganand Heera

### A Literary Restoration of the Maithili Ghazal

Writers unversed in the rigorous constraints of prosody and meter frequently assert that the inaugural collection of Maithili Ghazals surfaced in 1981. Yet, a discerning critique reveals that the compositions within that volume align more closely with the traditions of song and verse than with the specific architecture of the Ghazal. In truth, the authentic genesis of the Maithili Ghazal collection occurred in 2008 with the publication of Vijaynath Jha’s seminal work, Ahink Lel (For You).

Following the emergence of specialized categories such as the 'Bal Ghazal' (Children’s Ghazal) and 'Bhakti Ghazal' (Devotional Ghazal), those lacking technical mastery of the craft began to inhabit these genres as well. While they claim that collections of such Ghazals have been published, these works—much like their predecessors—are merely poems or songs masquerading as Ghazals.

Beyond this contested lineage, there arose the 'Anchinhar Aakhar'—unrecognized voices emerging from a landscape once hostile to the disciplined, grammatical Ghazal. The effort to rectify this historical sequence is far more than a simple bibliographic adjustment; it is a structural act of literary justice. In the wake of Ashish Anchinhar’s influence, Kundan Kumar Karn and Abhilash Thakur have taken up the mantle, utilizing the modern forums of Facebook and WhatsApp to apprentice a new generation of writers. They are joined in this mission by Pradeep Pushp, Chandan Jha, and Rajeev Ranjan Mishra, all of whom serve as vital mentors to those aspiring to master this venerable art form.

## 2.5 The Era of Weakness: The Dark Interlude of Grammatically Incorrect Ghazal

Between the classical phase and the Anchinhar renaissance lies a period that might charitably be called the interlude of incorrect ghazal - or, in the terminology of the research documents, the "Era of Weakness." A significant decline occurred when weaker poets emerged who wrote ghazals without grammar, ignoring meter and rhyme. Poets began composing and publishing verse under the name ghazal that lacked the form's essential structural features: no consistent bahr, no correctly functioning qafiya, sometimes no proper matla. Collections of such verse were published, given the imprimatur of print publication, and circulated through Maithili literary networks.

The consequences were multiple and damaging. First, the reading public - especially those without deep knowledge of Urdu prosody - lost the ability to distinguish correct from incorrect ghazal. If published collections presented grammar-deficient verse as ghazal, readers had no reason to doubt that this was what ghazal looked like. Second, the critical apparatus of Maithili literary culture - journals, reviewers, literary gatherings - failed to identify and correct the error. The gatekeepers of literary quality, whether through ignorance or indifference, allowed the incorrect tradition to establish itself.

This led to a crisis: poets who did follow grammar - specifically Vijaynath Jha and Yoganand Heera - were erased from literary history by the dominant weak poets. The erasure was accomplished not through any formal critical dismissal - no one appears to have engaged with their work and found it wanting on technical grounds - but through the sheer displacement effect of a flood of incorrect ghazals that occupied the available institutional space. When the dominant conception of "Maithili ghazal" shifted toward metrically incorrect verse, the poets who were writing correctly became invisible: they did not fit the new, degraded definition, and the institutions that might have recognised their work had themselves been captured by the incorrect tradition. Consequently, entire collections of grammatically incorrect ghazals were published, flooding the market.

This period has left an institutional legacy that the Anchinhar movement continues to confront. Even today, poetry labelled "ghazal" in Maithili contexts sometimes exhibits the formal deficiencies of the dark interlude era. The separation was also exacerbated by historical pretenders who lacked mastery over the technical rigors of Beher-Kafiya (prosody and rhyme). By mislabelling standard poems and songs as "Ghazals" to secure their own historical legacies, these figures diluted the genre's technical integrity, causing a functional rift between the structural precision of the Ghazal and the narrative flow of Drama.

The movement's insistence on formal standards is therefore not pedantry but a necessary act of cultural recovery.

**Part III: The Formal Architecture of the Maithili Ghazal**

## 3.1 The Arabic-Persian Prosodic System: Bahr and Aruz

The ghazal's metrical system - the bahr - is derived from the Arabic 'aruz (prosody), attributed to the eighth-century scholar al-Khalil ibn Ahmad al-Farahidi, who classified the meters of Arabic poetry into a system of fifteen (later extended to sixteen) fundamental bahrs or "seas." Each bahr is defined by the arrangement of its fundamental metrical feet (arkan, singular rukn), which are themselves defined by patterns of long (long syllable = guru = 2) and short (short syllable = laghu = 1) syllables.

As the system passed into Persian and then Urdu, it underwent considerable adaptation. The Persian and Urdu aruz tradition acknowledges approximately nineteen principal bahrs in common use, with numerous sub-varieties (zihafat) produced by the addition, subtraction, or modification of feet from the basic patterns. The most important bahrs for Urdu ghazal include: Bahr-e-Hazaj (base pattern 1222, associated with Urdu's most melodious ghazals), Bahr-e-Ramal (base pattern 2121), Bahr-e-Rajaz (base pattern 2212), Bahr-e-Khamil (base pattern 1212 12), and Bahr-e-Mutaqarib (base pattern 221). The well-known "Bahere Asam" (Bahr-e-Asam, matrakram 2122-1222-2122) cited in Anchinhar Aakhar blog posts for specific ghazals exemplifies how this numerical notation system makes bahr identification and teaching practically accessible.

The taqti (scansion) process involves breaking every word of a ghazal into its constituent syllables, assigning a 1 (short/light, laghu) or 2 (long/heavy, guru) value to each, and verifying that the resulting numerical sequence matches the claimed bahr throughout every line of the poem. A ghazal in which any line fails to match the bahr - even by a single syllable - is metrically incorrect, regardless of how beautifully its content is expressed. This is the standard against which Anchinhar measures all ghazal composition. The methodology relies on the adjustment of Rukn (metrical feet) to suit the Deergh (long) and Laghu (short) syllable patterns natural to Maithili speech.

The adaptation of the ghazal to Maithili required significant formal negotiation. The standard ghazal structure - minimum five couplets (sher/bayt), a consistent metrical pattern (bahr) with the same mora count in every line, an opening couplet (matla) in which both misras carry the qafiya and radif, subsequent couplets where only the second misra carries these elements, and a closing couplet (maqta) bearing the poet's takhallus - had to be mapped onto a language whose prosodic conventions were built on Sanskrit-derived varna (syllable)

metres and Prakrit-derived matra (moraic) metres rather than the Arabic-derived aruz system of Urdu ghazal.

## 3.2 The Formal Elements Table

| Element | Classical Requirement | Maithili Implementation (Anchinhar) |
|---|---|---|
| Sher | Self-contained couplet of two misras; each sher emotionally complete and independent (wahdat al-bayt); minimum five shers per ghazal. | Fundamental compositional unit; independence strictly maintained; poets annotate bahr explicitly in publications. |
| Behr (Meter) | Fixed quantal pattern of long (guru/2) and short (laghu/1) syllables; derived from Arabic aruz; ~19 principal bahrs in Urdu tradition. | 19 identified Maithili Bahars including newly constructed ones (Bahar-e-Videha, Bahar-e-Govinda, etc.); numerical matrakram notation used for teaching; short bahr (chhoti bahar) especially cultivated. |
| Qaafiyaa (Rhyme) | Systematic phonological recurrence of consonant-vowel pattern in word immediately before Radif; strict rules catalogued in aruz manuals. | Vowel-consonant precision in Maithili script; common errors identified and catalogued in Ghazalsastram; surface rhyme without correct phonological patterning rejected. |
| Radif (Refrain) | Identical word or phrase following Qaafiyaa at end of every second misra; muraddaf (with radif) or gair-muraddaf | Adapted to Maithili postpositions (e.g., -ke, -e); resonates with the teka (refrain) tradition of Maithili |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | (without); creates incantatory effect. | devotional music. |
| Matla (Opening couplet) | Both misras must carry full Qaafiyaa + Radif; establishes sonic and metrical framework for entire poem. | Strictly enforced as formal foundation; failure to double the rhyme in matla considered a fundamental error. |
| Maqta (Closing couplet) | Poet's takhallus (pen name) conventionally embedded; personal and reflexive quality; poet's signature on the work. | 'Anchinhar' used as takhallus; Maithili-inflected pen names drawn from native semantic field (nativisation of takhallus). |
| Wahdat al-bayt | Independence of each sher; couplets need no narrative or logical connection; unified by bahr and rhyme alone. | Formally theorised in Ghazalsastram as the ghazal's most structurally distinctive feature; enables dramatic multi-tonal deployment. |

The Anchinhar Aakhar blog's live ghazals show poets annotating their metres explicitly: the ghazal by Jagadanand Jha 'Manu' published on the blog in January 2026 notes its metre as 'bahre asam, matraakram 2122-1222-2122' (an asymmetric metre), while his earlier ghazal from the same month is annotated '1222-112-2222-112 sab panti-me' (a different matra pattern consistent across all lines). This practice of explicit metrical notation - unusual in most vernacular ghazal traditions - signals the seriousness with which the Maithili ghazal community is theorising its own formal practice.

## 3.3 Translating Bahr to Maithili: The Phonological Challenge

The application of the bahr system to Maithili presents genuine phonological challenges that Ashish Anchinhar's theoretical work has addressed systematically. Maithili is a language of the Magadhi-Prakrit branch of the Indo-Aryan family, spoken across northern Bihar and the Terai of Nepal. Its phonological features include: a rich system of front vowels (including the distinctive Maithili schwa-like vowels), nasalisation patterns (including

chandrabindu and anusvara whose distribution differs from Hindi), consonant gemination, a distinctive verbal morphology, and certain tonal features in its northern dialects. Maithili phonetics favour extended "Deergh" (long) sequences. By formalising structures like 22-22-22-22-21, the poet is granted more flexibility to use Maithili vocabulary without "forcing" words into foreign rhythmic moulds.

In the Arabic-Persian bahr system, syllable weight is determined by the structure of the syllable: a syllable ending in a short vowel is "light" (1); a syllable ending in a long vowel, a diphthong, or a consonant is "heavy" (2). The challenge arises because Maithili words may have syllabic weight patterns that do not map cleanly onto any of the nineteen classical bahrs. A bahr that scans perfectly in Urdu - whose vocabulary is enriched by long-vowelled Persian and Arabic loanwords - may require significant phonological contortion when applied to Maithili's native vocabulary.

Anchinhar's analytical approach addresses this in three ways: First, identifying which of the nineteen classical bahrs can be applied to Maithili without distorting the language's natural rhythmic patterns; Second, examining how other Indian languages (Bengali, Gujarati, Marathi, Telugu, Hindi) have adapted the bahr system to their phonological needs, deriving comparative lessons; Third, proposing modified or new Maithili-specific bahrs where no classical bahr accommodates natural Maithili speech rhythms.

The blog's pedagogical approach - illustrated by using bahr analysis of familiar Hindi film songs and bhajans as teaching tools - makes this abstract prosodic system tangible and learnable. Since many Maithili speakers know popular Hindi film music, hearing that a familiar song corresponds to, say, Bahr-e-Ramal gives the learner an embodied sense of what that meter sounds like before they encounter it in abstract notation. This approach - the Hindi Filmi Geet me Bahr (Bahr in Hindi Film Songs) section of the blog - is among its most pedagogically ingenious contributions.

## 3.4 Qafiya: The Grammar of Rhyme

The qafiya (rhyme) in the ghazal is not simply an end-rhyme in the English poetic sense. It is a systematic and technically demanding phonological requirement with specific rules about what counts as correct rhyme. In the classical Arabic-Persian-Urdu tradition, qafiya is analysed in terms of the specific consonant and vowel patterns that must recur. "Rudad-al-qafiya" (rhyme defects) - the technical errors in rhyme construction - are catalogued in classical manuals of aruz: including errors of syllabic correspondence (ta'asuf),

errors of vowel correspondence (iqa'), and repetition of the same word in the rhyming position (ikfa').

In the Maithili context, the most common qafiya error in incorrect ghazals is the use of words that rhyme on a surface level (same final vowel, for example) but do not share the correct phonological patterning of a true qafiya. The Anchinhar movement's insistence on correct qafiya is therefore not a matter of aesthetic preference but of formal integrity: a poem without correct qafiya is simply not a ghazal, whatever label it carries. Another key question was the takhallus. In the Urdu tradition, the pen name incorporated into the maqta is often an Arabic or Persian word with literary resonance. In Maithili, poets have adopted Maithili-inflected takhallusei: Anchinhar ('the unrecognised one'), Manu (the name of the mythic lawgiver but also a common Maithili name), and others whose pen names are drawn from the language's own semantic field. This nativisation of the takhallus is emblematic of the broader project of domesticating the ghazal form within a Maithili cultural imaginary.

## 3.5 Radif: The Incantatory Refrain

The radif (refrain) is the feature that gives the ghazal its most distinctive sonic character: the hypnotic repetition of an identical word or phrase at the close of each sher's second line. The radif can be a single word ("aaj" - today), a phrase ("dekh nahin sakta" - cannot see), or even a grammatical ending. The effect of the radif depends on the paradox of sameness-in-difference: the same words appear at the end of every sher, but each sher places those words in a new context, illuminating the radif from a new angle. The result is a cumulative emotional and semantic enrichment - the repeated word becoming more complex and resonant with each new sher.

This structural feature has deep affinities with the musical forms of Mithila - particularly the Dhumal and devotional kirtan traditions, in which a refrain line (teka) is repeated as a community response to each verse of a longer composition. The Maithili ghazal's radif can be experienced as a formalisation of this communal refrain tradition: every reader/listener "sings" the refrain internally after each sher, participating in the poem's communal movement.

# Part IV: The Anchinhar Aakhar Movement - Revitalisation and Digital Democracy

## 4.1 The Name and Its Significance

"Anchinhar Aakhar" - literally, "Unknown Letters" or "Unrecognised Script" - is a name of considerable resonance in the context of the Maithili ghazal revival. In Maithili, 'anchinhar' means 'unrecognised' or 'unfamiliar,' and 'aakhar' means 'letters' or 'words.' On one level, it evokes the literal condition of Tirhuta (Mithilakshar), the indigenous script of Mithila, which has been rendered "unknown" to most contemporary Maithili speakers by the dominance of Devanagari in education and administration. On another level, it evokes the condition of the correct ghazal tradition itself in the period before the movement: a tradition rendered invisible - "unrecognised" - by the dominance of incorrect practice. And on a third level, it speaks to the movement's constituency: poets and readers who are "new" to the ghazal's formal vocabulary, who approach it as unknown letters whose meaning must be learned. This dual resonance - simultaneously aesthetic and political - is characteristic of the Parallel Literature Movement's sensibility.

The movement began on April 11, 2008, with the launch of the "Anchinhar Aakhar" (A-Aa) blog by Ashish Anchinhar, later co-edited by Gajendra Thakur. This era, often termed the "Anchinhar Era" of Maithili Ghazal, utilised the internet to bypass traditional publishing gatekeepers, successfully bringing 350 to 400 new and previously marginalised writers into the literary mainstream within a single decade. The blog's subtitle - "A Research Blog on Maithili Ghazal and Sher-o-Shayari" - makes the scholarly orientation explicit. This is not primarily a creative writing platform (though it publishes creative work); it is a research and educational institution in digital form, dedicated to the systematic study and dissemination of knowledge about the ghazal form.

The movement had two primary goals: (1) To restore the classical Behr and Qaafiyaa. (2) To reintroduce complex, unfamiliar, and precise vocabulary lost in the "weak era." For decades, despite poets like Vijaynath Jha and Yoganand Heera writing correctly, there was no means to learn Ghazal writing in Maithili. No textbooks, no grammar manuals, no ilm-behr (science of meter) existed. The Anchinhar movement solved this by moving online, creating digital tools and a Wikipedia presence, thus democratising access to the form.

## 4.2 The Architecture of the Anchinhar Aakhar Blog

The Anchinhar Aakhar blog is organised into a comprehensive set of sections, each addressing a different dimension of ghazal knowledge. The structure of the blog itself constitutes a curriculum - a systematic progression from theoretical foundations to practical creative work. This architecture mirrors the structure of a classical Ustad-Shagird (master-disciple) literary institution, in which the master provides theoretical grounding, critical feedback, creative models, and performance opportunities. The difference is that the Anchinhar Aakhar blog does this publicly, in digital form, accessible to anyone with internet access - the opposite of the exclusionary guru-shishya system that historically restricted literary knowledge to social elites.

Key sections of the blog include:

- **Ghazal Sastra Aalekh (Theoretical Articles on Ghazal):** Systematic expositions of bahr, qafiya, radif, matla, maqta, takhallus, and other formal elements, in Maithili. This section constitutes the Ghazalsastram - the first body of Maithili-language theoretical writing on the ghazal form.
- **Hindi Filmi Geet me Bahr (Bahr in Hindi Film Songs):** A pedagogically ingenious section that maps the abstract numerical notations of the bahr system onto familiar popular songs, making prosody learnable through embodied familiarity.
- **Bhajan par Ghazal ka Prabhav (The Influence of Ghazal on Bhajans):** Exploring deep historical connections between the devotional song tradition of Mithila and the ghazal's formal features.
- **Anya Bharatiya Bhasha ke Ghazal me Bahr (Bahr in the Ghazals of Other Indian Languages):** Comparative section examining Bengali, Gujarati, Marathi, Telugu, and Hindi ghazal traditions, providing both models and cautionary examples for the Maithili project.
- **Samiksha/Alochana/Samalochana (Criticism and Review):** Maintaining critical standards necessary for a living literary tradition; reviews of published Maithili ghazal work, identification of formal errors, praise of correct practice.
- **Ghazalkar Parichay Shrinkhala (Ghazalkar Introduction Series):** Systematic introductions to individual Maithili ghazal poets - including historical figures, contemporary practitioners, and poets from the wider Sher-o-Shayari tradition.
- **Vishva Ghazalkar Parichay Shrinkhala (World Ghazal Poet Introduction Series):** Situating Maithili ghazal practice within the global ghazal tradition.

- **Chhanda Sastra (Prosody):** Broader discussions of prosodic principles across traditions.
- **Ghazal ka Iskool (School of Ghazal):** The most directly pedagogical section - structured teaching materials for aspiring ghazal writers; a democratic pedagogical resource making formal rules accessible to any Maithili writer regardless of traditional Sanskrit-prosody education.
- **Anchinhar Aakhar ki Rachana Sansar (Ashish Anchinhar's Creative World):** The poet's own creative output.
- **Online Mushaira:** The digital mushaira platform, allowing poets from across the Maithili-speaking world to participate in the communal performance dimension of ghazal culture.

The most extensive criticism of the Maithili Ghazal to date has been written through the medium of Anchinhar Aakhar.

## 4.3 Digital Democratisation and the Maithili Diaspora

The decision to operate primarily through a blog platform was not merely a practical convenience but a structural choice with profound implications for who could participate in the Maithili ghazal tradition. The Maithili-speaking world is geographically dispersed: Bihar, Nepal's Madhesh region, Kolkata, Delhi, Mumbai, and the global Maithili diaspora in the United States, Canada, the UK, and the Gulf. Print publication - the traditional medium of literary legitimation - requires physical distribution infrastructure that cannot reach all these communities equitably.

The blog dissolves this geographical barrier. A ghazal published on Anchinhar Aakhar is simultaneously accessible in Darbhanga, Janakpur, Kolkata, and New York. A poet in the Terai of Nepal can participate in the online mushaira as a full equal of a poet in Patna. Critical feedback from Ashish Anchinhar can reach a new poet in the diaspora within minutes of submission. The 'Anchinhar Aakhar' Ghazal movement extends as far as Nepal. The digital medium thus enacts in practice the democratic literary culture that the Parallel Literature Movement advocates in theory.

Furthermore, the digital medium bypasses the caste-based gatekeeping that has characterised Maithili print literary institutions. The Akademi-affiliated journals, publishing houses, and literary organisations have historically been dominated by upper-caste (particularly Brahmin and Kayastha) literary figures. Submission to these institutions has required not just literary quality but social connections and cultural capital that are unevenly distributed. The Anchinhar Aakhar blog and the Videha eJournal accept submissions on the basis of literary

quality alone - specifically, on the basis of formal correctness in the ghazal's case. This criterion, while demanding, is in principle equally accessible to any poet willing to learn the form's requirements.

### 4.4 Prominent Ghazal Writers from the Anchinhar Aakhar Movement

Some of the prominent ghazal writers who emerged from Anchinhar Aakhar include:

- Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil'
- Kundan Kumar Karn (Nepal)
- Rajeev Ranjan Mishra
- Chandan Jha
- Pradeep Pushpa
- Jagdanand Jha 'Manu' (active contributor 2024–26; ghazals published with explicit matrakram annotation)
- Om Prakash Jha
- Abhilash Thakur
- Shantilaxmi Choudhry

## Part V: Ashish Anchinhar - "The Other Name of Maithili Ghazal"

### 5.1 Portrait of a Literary Movement

Ashish Anchinhar - the pen name of the poet, blogger, and critic who is most closely identified with the revitalisation of the Maithili ghazal - has been described, in a widely circulated characterisation, as "the other name of Maithili ghazal." Based in Kolkata (a city with a significant Maithili diaspora), Anchinhar has since the 2010s emerged as both a practitioner and a theorist of the ghazal form in Maithili. His blog, Anchinhar Aakhar (anchinharakharkolkata.blogspot.com), is described in its header as "A Research Blog On Maithili Ghazal and Sher-o-Shayari," and its extensive contents - spanning formal analysis, historical research, criticism, poet profiles, audio-video archives, and online mushairas - constitute the most comprehensive single resource on Maithili ghazal in the digital age. His sustained commitment - maintained over many years, without the institutional

support of a university position, literary foundation, or Akademi affiliation - has been remarkable in its range and consistency.

As a poet, Anchinhar is known particularly for ghazals composed in short bahrs (chhoti bahar) - the technically most demanding category, because the shorter the metrical unit, the less room there is for the small phonological liberties (inaccuracies in syllable weight) that longer bahrs can absorb. His shers are characterised by a lapidary compression: few words, sharp images, concentrated emotional force. He composes in multiple modes: classical love ghazal, Bhakti ghazal, Bal ghazal (for children), and social-commentary ghazal.

As a theorist, his contributions to Ghazalsastram are original and systematic. No Maithili scholar had previously produced a comprehensive account of how the bahr system should be applied to Maithili - which bahrs work, which need modification, which new frameworks may be needed. This theoretical work is not abstract; it is practically oriented toward enabling correct composition. The blog's numerical notation system for bahr (matrakram) is itself a pedagogical innovation: it makes the meter learnable from a written page, rather than requiring years of immersion in a traditional guru-shishya relationship.

As an archivist and cultural historian, his book Maithili Web Patrakaritak Itihas (A History of Maithili Web Journalism, Shashi Prakashan, 2023) provides the most comprehensive account available of how Maithili literary culture found its primary institutional home in the digital medium from the 1990s onwards. The book situates the ghazal revival within the broader narrative of Maithili's digital renaissance, ensuring that this history is preserved and interpretable.

His collaboration on Maithili Wikipedia and with Gajendra Thakur and Videha (which played a crucial role in the Wikipedia project between 2008 and 2013) demonstrates the institutionally collaborative nature of his work: he has consistently understood his project as collective rather than individual, building an ecosystem rather than a personal reputation.

## 5.2 Ashish Anchinhar's Five Central Contributions

6. Authoring Maithili Ghazalak Vyakarana o Itihasa (Grammar and History of Maithili Ghazal) - providing the systematic theoretical framework for contemporary poets.
7. Constructing new Bahars specific to Maithili phonetics.
8. Reviving and restoring the forgotten poets Vijaynath Jha and Yoganand Heera to their proper place in the correct lineage.

9. Reconverging Ghazal with Maithili drama (2026).
10. Leading the Wikipedia digitisation - preventing the historical erasure suffered by Vijaynath Jha and Yoganand Heera from recurring.

*"Ashish Anchinhar is the other name of Maithili gazal. His gazals are mostly of small width (bahar) though sharp ones. They have a valuable contribution in removing the notion that Ghazal style as the real heritage of Urdu. Maithili will always remember them for this."*

## Part VI: Theoretical Foundation - Ghazalsastram

A critical contribution of the Anchinhar Aakhar movement was the introduction of strict prosody and grammatical discipline to the Maithili Ghazal. Prior to this revival, many writers ignored the formal rules of the genre. To address this, Gajendra Thakur, recognised as Maithili's first "Aruji" (scholar of ghazal prosody), authored the first Ghajalsastram (Maithili Ghazal Poetics). Furthermore, Ashish Anchinhar published Maithili Ghazalak Vyakarana o Itihasa (Grammar and History of Maithili Ghazal), which provided a systematic theoretical framework for contemporary poets.

The term Ghazalsastram - combining the Persian-Arabic "ghazal" with the Sanskrit "sastra" (systematic knowledge, theory, science) - captures the distinctive intellectual project of the Anchinhar era: the creation of a rigorous, systematic, Sanskrit-rooted theoretical framework for a form that arrived from the Arabic-Persian literary tradition. This is itself a significant cultural act: it claims the ghazal for the Sanskrit sastra tradition, asserting that the form's formal demands are not "foreign" impositions but can be domesticated within Mithila's own deep tradition of systematic linguistic and literary knowledge - a tradition that gave the world Navya-Nyaya philosophy and the Panini-derived grammatical tradition.

The movement's masterstroke was the creation of Ghajalsastram (The Grammar of Ghazal). For the first time in Maithili history, this text provided comprehensive coverage of the following:

- The definition and history of the ghazal form, situating Maithili practice within the global tradition

- A systematic account of the bahr system and its adaptation to Maithili phonology, including identification of which classical bahrs work in Maithili and proposals for modified or new frameworks where necessary
- The rules of Behr (meters like Mutaqarab, Hazaj, Ramal)
- The rules of Qaafiyaa (end rhyme) and Radif (the repeating word/phrase); a rigorous account of qafiya and its proper functioning in Maithili, with examples of correct and incorrect practice
- An account of radif, its history, its varieties, and its emotional and semantic functions
- The formal requirements of the matla, maqta, and takhallus
- The criterion of wahdat al-bayt (independence of each sher) and its relationship to the ghazal's structural logic
- The typology of ghazal sub-forms (muraddaf, gair-muraddaf, Bhakti ghazal, Bal ghazal)
- A comparative account of ghazal prosody in other Indian languages
- A structural guide to distinguish a true Ghazal from a mere lyric

This body of theoretical writing - distributed across the Anchinhar Aakhar blog's "Ghazal Sastra Aalekh" and "Chhanda Sastra" sections - constitutes the first comprehensive Maithili-language theoretical account of the ghazal. Its existence transforms the status of the Maithili ghazal from a creative practice transmitted informally to a formally theorised discipline with explicit, teachable standards. This transformation is the precondition for the pedagogical project - the "Ghazal ka Iskool" - that the movement conducts through the blog.

# Part VII: Construction of New Maithili Bahars - Analysis by Ashish Anchinhar

## 7.1 Conceptual Framework: Nativisation of Prosody

The formalisation of new rhythmic structures (Bahars) specifically tailored for Maithili literature represents one of Ashish Anchinhar's most technically significant contributions. The core thesis of this movement is the nativisation of prosody: transitioning away from strictly Persian or Urdu nomenclature and structural constraints to reflect the phonetic reality of the Maithili language and honour its literary icons.

The methodology relies on the adjustment of Rukn (metrical feet) to suit the Deergh (long) and Laghu (short) syllable patterns natural to Maithili speech. While classical meters provide a foundation, the specific "flow" of Maithili

requires unique syllable weight distributions - often involving clusters of long syllables that are less common in traditional Urdu Ghazals. Anchinhar's framework analysis identified three categories of Bahars in Maithili ghazal: Bahars borrowed from Arabic/Persian (Classical); Bahars adapted from Maithili folk songs (Indigenous); and Hybrid Bahars unique to Maithili syntax.

## 7.2 The Newly Constructed Maithili Bahars

| Bahar Name | Rhythmic Pattern (Matrakram) | Rationale & Etymology |
|---|---|---|
| Bahar-e-Videha | 22-22-22-22-21 or 22-22-22-22-22-1 | Named after the Videha e-journal and the ancient name of Mithila. Focuses on a heavy start with a laghu (short) resolution. |
| Bahar-e-Govinda | 1-22-22-22-22 | An inversion of Videha. Named after Pandit Govinda Jha, architect of modern Maithili grammar. |
| Bahar-e-Lochan | 22-22-22-22-121 | Features a short-long-short (121) cadence. Named after the influential litterateur Ramlochan Thakur. |
| Bahar-e-Pradeep | 212-212-1222 | A modification of Khafif Musaddas. Named after the lyricist Maithiliputra Pradeep. |
| Bahar-e-Roop | Based on 2221 | A rhythmic foot harmonised for Maithili satire. Named after the satirist Roopkant Thakur. |

## 7.3 Linguistic Significance and Cultural Reclamation

Phonetic Compatibility: The Maithili phonetics favour extended "Deergh" sequences. By formalising structures like 22-22-22-22-21, the poet is granted more flexibility to use Maithili vocabulary without "forcing" words into foreign

rhythmic moulds. This is the central linguistic justification for constructing new bahars rather than simply importing classical ones.

Cultural Reclamation: By naming meters after figures like Govinda Jha and Roopkant Thakur, the framework creates a "literary map" within the structure itself. It transforms the Ghazal from a borrowed form into a native Maithili vessel. The Videha Influence: The significance of Bahar-e-Videha highlights the role of modern digital platforms (like the Videha e-journal) in stabilising and documenting new linguistic standards.

The "Construction of New Bahars" by Ashish Anchinhar represents a significant step in the evolution of the Maithili Ghazal. It moves beyond mere imitation, establishing a technical and symbolic framework that is authentically Maithil. This approach ensures that the "rhythm" of the language is preserved while honouring the giants of its literary history.

# Part VIII: Expanding the Genre - Bal Ghazal and Bhakti Ghazal

## 8.1 Bal Ghazal: The Ghazal Speaks to Children

The Bal (Children's) ghazal is among the most creative formal innovations of the Anchinhar era. The classical ghazal - in every language in which it has been written - is an adult form: its dominant themes (erotic longing, spiritual anguish, the pain of separation, the intoxication of love) and its characteristic emotional register presuppose an adult consciousness. Even the Bhakti ghazal, devotional in content, is addressed to adult devotional experience. The Anchinhar Aakhar movement is credited with birthing the Bal-Ghazal (Children's Ghazals) as a distinct sub-genre, with Videha Issue 111 dedicated entirely to this form.

To compose a Bal ghazal - maintaining full formal correctness in bahr and qafiya while adapting content, vocabulary, and emotional register to a young audience - requires creative solutions to several simultaneous constraints. The bahr must be maintained: no concession to prosodic correctness is made simply because the subject matter is childhood. The vocabulary must be accessible to children but still poetically resonant. The emotional content must be warm, engaging, and age-appropriate, without condescension. Light meters and child-friendly themes characterise this sub-genre.

The Bal ghazal's formal innovations have both creative and pedagogical dimensions. Creatively, they expand the ghazal's thematic range into territory that the classical tradition never explored, demonstrating the form's adaptability without sacrificing its integrity. Pedagogically, Bal ghazals can introduce younger readers to the ghazal form through subjects they recognise and emotions they experience - their own world made formally beautiful, rather than the adult world of longing and loss that dominates classical ghazal. The cultivation of Bal ghazal is also a demographic investment in the future of the Maithili ghazal tradition: by creating ghazals that speak to children, the movement builds a constituency for the form among the next generation of Maithili speakers.

## 8.2 Bhakti Ghazal: The Devotional Reconvergence

The Bhakti ghazal draws on the deepest roots of Maithili literary culture. The Maithili devotional tradition - shaped by Vidyapati's nachari (songs to Shiva) and Vaishnava padavali, and continued by poets including Madhup - is characterised by an intense, personal, emotionally direct relationship with the divine. The devotee addresses God in the language of human love - as beloved, as friend, as absent lord - with a directness and intimacy that parallels the Sufi ghazal's spiritual register. Under the Anchinhar framework, the Ghazal was no longer confined to secular love (ishq) or wine (sharaab). The Bhakti-Ghazal (Devotional Ghazals) reintegrated spiritual themes into the ghazal structure, with Videha Issue 126 exemplifying this sub-genre.

The Bhakti ghazal synthesises these two traditions: it brings the ghazal's formal architecture (bahr, qafiya, radif, matla, maqta) into service of the devotional imagination native to Mithila. The effect is a form that is simultaneously structured and fervent, classical and immediate, Persian in its prosody and Maithili in its spirit. Ashish Anchinhar's own Bhakti ghazals - noted in the blog's monthly summaries - demonstrate this synthesis in practice. The blog section titled "Bhajan par Ghazal ka Prabhav" (The Influence of Ghazal on Bhajans) explores this relationship historically, showing how the ghazal's formal features have influenced the bhajan tradition even outside the explicit context of ghazal composition. This historical argument - that the ghazal and the Maithili devotional song tradition have been in dialogue for longer than the explicit practice of Maithili ghazal writing acknowledges - further supports the claim that the ghazal is not a foreign import but a form with deep indigenous resonance. The devotional tradition of using the language of spiritual love for

divine (Sufi-metaphysical Behr) maps naturally onto Maithili bhakti sensibility.

# Part IX: Institutional Independence, Awards, and the Silencing of Women

## 9.1 Independence from the Akademi System

The Maithili literary establishment - centred on the Sahitya Akademi's Maithili wing, the Maithili Akademi of Bihar, and associated print publishers - has historically operated within social and ideological structures that the Parallel Literature Movement regards as fundamentally compromised. The Akademi system has been criticised for: awarding recognition primarily to upper-caste male authors; privileging Sanskrit-influenced, "classical" literary registers over vernacular, folk, and subaltern traditions; maintaining an informal blacklist of authors associated with progressive or politically inconvenient literary positions; and failing to represent the full geographic and social diversity of the Maithili-speaking world.

As part of its mission to establish a "parallel" institutional identity, the Anchinhar Aakhar movement created the "Ghazal Kamla-Kosi-Bagmati-Mahananda Samman." This was the first independent award specifically dedicated to the ghazal genre in Maithili, reflecting the movement's broader struggle against the "onslaught on dignity" by state-funded academies which parallel historians argue have historically marginalised non-elitist genres. The Anchinhar-Videha network has consistently maintained its independence from the Akademi system. Its criteria of value - formal correctness in the case of the ghazal, literary quality and originality more broadly - are explicitly different from the institutional criteria of the Akademi system, which have been influenced by social and political considerations.

This independence is not merely principled but strategic: a movement that sought recognition from the Akademi system would necessarily internalise the Akademi's criteria and social values, gradually becoming indistinguishable from the institution it sought to reform. By maintaining complete institutional independence - publishing in its own digital platforms, developing its own award structures, cultivating its own community of poets and readers - the movement preserves the integrity of its alternative literary vision. The Anchinhar movement also created parallel institutions: online mushairas

(poetry gatherings), digital qaafiyaa dictionaries, and the Ghajalsastram press. This is institutionalisation without physical hegemony.

## 9.2 Women in the Maithili Ghazal Tradition

Despite a rich history dating back to the 18th century, women's writing remains an "invisible" canon due to institutional neglect. RTI data compiled by Vinit Utpal and Ashish Anchinhar (2011–2014) reveals that the Sahitya Akademi excluded women, effectively silencing their contribution to the literary canon. The relationship between the Maithili ghazal and women's literary voices is complicated by Mithila's powerful patriarchal social structure. The Mithila Brahminical social order - with its emphasis on the Panjika genealogical system, gotra endogamy, and strict gender roles - has historically constrained women's participation in formal literary culture. The literary gatherings (mushairas and kavita sammelans) of the traditional Maithili literary establishment were predominantly male spaces. Women's literary production was often confined to the domestic sphere - folk songs (such as the Sohar, Kajri, and Saumang traditions) performed at life-cycle rituals - which, while culturally vital, were systematically excluded from the formal canon.

The Anchinhar Aakhar movement actively fought against the silencing of women in Maithili poetry. In the Ghazal Award certificates, honorific titles were given to women first and then to men; this was one of several steps taken toward this end. By establishing institutional independence outside the traditional (male-dominated) Videha network, the movement created a safe, rule-governed space for female ghazal writers to emerge and be recognised. The digital medium itself has structural advantages in this regard: a woman poet can submit a ghazal to an online platform without the social exposure and potential vulnerability of presenting at a physical literary gathering; her work is evaluated on its formal merits without the filter of social propriety that might discourage female participation in traditional literary institutions.

The Videha eJournal's editorial policy - which explicitly welcomes work from poets of all castes and communities - extends this democratic commitment. Gajendra Thakur's sustained editorial effort to publish women authors of Maithili has made Videha one of the most gender-inclusive Maithili literary platforms in existence. For the ghazal specifically, this inclusion means that the Maithili tradition is developing women's voices in the form at the same time as it is establishing the form's formal standards - a simultaneity that gives the tradition a democratic character from its revival phase onwards, rather than having to retrofit inclusion after the fact.

# Part X: Structural Symbiosis of Maithili Ghazal and Drama - A Century of Divergence and the 2026 Reconvergence

## 10.1 The Shared Genesis and the Dramatic Tradition

At the dawn of the 20th century, modern Maithili drama and the Maithili Ghazal were inextricably linked, often birthed by the same authors within the same textual space - most significantly by Pandit Jivan Jha in Sundar-Samyog. The relationship between the Maithili ghazal and Maithili drama is one of the most intellectually stimulating structural facts in the tradition's history. Maithili drama has a rich heritage. The Ankiya Naat tradition of Assam (which has deep connections to the Vaishnavism that Vidyapati helped inspire) uses lyric inserts - padas and songs - as primary vehicles of emotional expression within a dramatic frame. The Kirtaniya Naat tradition specific to Mithila develops this further: it is a form of musical drama in which narrative and lyric are interwoven, and in which the performance of songs (geet) provides emotional counterpoint to the dramatic action. In both these theatrical traditions, the lyric insert functions as the drama's emotional climax - the moment when feeling exceeds what prose or narrative can contain, and the character breaks into song.

The ghazal's formal structure makes it particularly well-suited to this dramatic function. Each sher, being self-contained and emotionally complete, can express a different facet of a character's feeling without requiring narrative coherence between them. A character in the extremity of loss can sing a ghazal in which each sher approaches that loss from a different angle - through memory, through futility, through anger, through resignation - without the shers needing to tell a coherent story. A five-couplet Ghazal provides a director with five distinct emotional "shifts." This structural autonomy mirrors the evolving moods and physical movements of a play, allowing for a more nuanced and dynamic integration of music and text than a single-themed poem can provide. The radif's repetition creates the music of obsessive emotion appropriate to dramatic climax; the matla establishes the emotional key in which the scene will be played.

## 10.2 A Century of Divergence (1920s–2020s)

Following the nascent period of shared genesis, a significant divergence occurred. For over a century - from the 1920s through the 2020s - drama and ghazal remained distinct forms. Drama became action-oriented; ghazal became

lyric-oriented. This separation was exacerbated by the historical pretenders who lacked mastery over the technical rigors of Beher-Kafiya. By mislabelling standard poems and songs as "Ghazals" to secure their own historical legacies, these figures diluted the genre's technical integrity, causing a functional rift between the structural precision of the Ghazal and the narrative flow of Drama. The Ghazal's forms diverged: drama developed through its own channels, without the ghazal as a systematic element. The creation of modern Maithili plays and ghazals, once unified by the same author, became increasingly separate endeavours.

## 10.3 The 2026 Reconvergence: Case Study of Sakha

The 120-year hiatus of this inter-disciplinary union concluded on February 17, 2026. The staging of the play Sakha - penned, directed, and performed by Pawan Jha (Kashyap Kamal) and featuring Sunitha Jha - integrated a contemporary Ghazal ("Apan aukat anurupe vidhata taki lene chhi" of Ashish Anchinhar) as a core narrative element. This production, spearheaded by the Achhinjal team, represents a milestone in reclaiming the "Aroozi" (prosodic) traditions within a theatrical framework.

The 2026 reconvergence - the reintegration of grammatically correct Maithili ghazal into dramatic performance - recovers this original relationship and, crucially, does so with the formal rigour that the Anchinhar era has established. Ghazals embedded in a 2026 Maithili drama are correctly metered, correctly rhymed - because the standards of correct ghazal practice are now established and teachable, whereas they were obscured during the dark interlude. In a parallel reference from the documents, Jeevan Jha's Sunder-Sanyog, the Modern is described as a contemporary adaptation of Jeevan Jha's original play, deliberately reintegrating the Ghazal into the dramatic structure, restoring the original symbiosis and completing a 100-year cycle.

## 10.4 Theoretical Framework: Structural Efficacy of the Ghazal in Theatre

The argument for the Ghazal as a superior theatrical tool rests on a comparative analysis of its internal architecture against that of the traditional poem (Kavita) or song (Geet):

- **Linearity vs. Independence:** Traditional songs are generally bound to a singular emotional arc or theme, which can limit a director's ability to pivot within a scene.

- **The Multi-Vocality of the Sher:** In contrast, the Ghazal is composed of independent couplets (Shers). Each Sher is a self-contained unit of thought and emotion. A five-couplet Ghazal provides five distinct emotional "shifts," matching the evolving moods and physical movements of a play.
- **The Lyric Insert Tradition:** The "lyric insert within drama" structure - a character's intensely felt moment expressed in a formally distinct lyric mode - appears across world theatrical traditions: the aria in European opera, the pada in Sanskrit drama (Natya Sastra), the song in Elizabethan drama. The Maithili ghazal's reintegration into drama places it within this universal theatrical structure, while marking it as distinctively Maithili in its formal character.

Several empirical questions must be addressed by practitioners and witnesses (referred to as the "Sanjayas" of the performance) as this reintegration develops: What is the quantifiable impact of a structurally sound Ghazal on audience reception compared to traditional lyrical forms? How can theatrical training be updated to help directors distinguish between authentic Beher-Kafiya Ghazals and pseudo-Ghazals? What interventions are required to improve the orthography and phonetics of Ghazal singers to meet the demands of high-quality theatrical acoustics?

The "meeting" of genres witnessed in 2026 is not merely a nostalgic revival but a technical necessity for the evolution of Maithili literature. By restoring the Ghazal to the stage, creators can leverage its inherent structural flexibility to enhance the emotional depth and movement of Maithili drama.

## Part XI: Maithili Ghazal and Wikipedia

The relationship between the Maithili ghazal revival and the Maithili Wikipedia is a distinctive feature of the movement's digital character. According to Ashish Anchinhar's Maithili Web Patrakaritak Itihas, the systematic creation of Maithili Wikipedia content - including articles on Maithili literature, literary figures, and cultural history - created a permanent, publicly accessible, Maithili-language encyclopaedic reference infrastructure.

The movement leveraged Wikipedia to create a permanent, verifiable archive. Key contributions included pages for Maithili Ghazal, Ghajalsastram, and Anchinhar Aakhar; standardised romanisation and scansion of Maithili Behr; and documentation of the correct lineage of poets. This prevented the historical erasure - suffered by Vijaynath Jha and Yoganand Heera - from happening

again. You are also invited to contribute to the Wikipedia article on Maithili Ghazal (mai.wikipedia.org).

This Wikipedia work matters for the ghazal revival in several ways. First: encyclopaedic articles on Maithili ghazal history - on Pandit Jivan Jha, Sitaram Jha, Madhup, Vijayanaatha Jha, Yogananda Hira, and Ashish Anchinhar himself - create a documented historical record accessible to any internet user. The ghazal tradition, previously at risk of being entirely erased from institutional memory, acquires the permanence of encyclopaedic documentation. Second: the Wikipedia platform's editorial standards - which require verifiability and neutral point of view - provide a different kind of legitimacy than the self-publication of the blog or the institutional legitimacy of the Akademi. A Maithili Wikipedia article about the Anchinhar movement can be cited by students, scholars, and journalists, becoming part of the evidentiary record of Maithili cultural history. Third: the multilingual nature of Wikipedia - its articles are linked across languages through Wikidata - means that a Maithili Wikipedia article on the ghazal tradition connects to Arabic, Persian, Urdu, Bengali, Marathi, and English Wikipedia articles on related topics. This cross-linking situates the Maithili ghazal within the global encyclopaedic narrative of world literature, giving it a comparative context and an international visibility that no single-language platform can provide.

## Part XII: The Parallel Literature Movement and Videha - Institutional Context

To understand the ghazal revival, one must first understand the movement within which it occurred. The Videha Maithili Literature Movement, initiated by Gajendra Thakur (born 1971) through his blog 'Bhalsarik Gachh' from 5 July 2004 onwards - rechristened as the fortnightly e-journal Videha (ISSN 2229-547X) from 1 January 2008 - represents the most significant intervention in Maithili literary culture since the colonial-era journals of the early twentieth century. Thakur, a palaeographer and lexicographer who had earlier deciphered 11,000 palm-leaf Panji inscriptions in Tirhuta script, launched Videha explicitly as a 'parallel' literary platform: parallel to the Sahitya Akademi-aligned institutional Maithili literature, which he and others accused of being dominated by a narrow upper-caste Brahmin network that systematically excluded Dalit, lower-caste, and non-traditional voices.

The concept of 'Parallel Literature' in Maithili - articulated by Gajendra Thakur and documented extensively in his blog posts - draws on the broader Indian

Dalit and subaltern literary movements of the 1970s–90s, but contextualises it within Mithila's specific caste topology. The parallel stream includes not only Dalit and OBC writers (Jagadish Prasad Mandal, Rajdeo Mandal, Umesh Paswan) but also writers who formally and aesthetically challenged the orthodoxies of the dominant tradition - including the ghazal writers, whose choice of form was itself an act of cultural transgression. The Videha institution represented the established caste-dominated mainstream, yet the Anchinhar movement operated as a Parallel Literature Movement, rejecting the gatekeeping while borrowing its archival rigor. This created a healthy dialectic: one traditional, one structuralist-digital.

As Mithilesh Kumar Jha documents in India Seminar (2021), Videha 'provided an excellent platform to new and emerging Maithili writers, the most notable among them Jagadish Prasad Mandal, Rajdeo Mandal, Umesh Paswan, Munnaji, Ashish Anchinhar, Chandan Kumar Jha, among others.' The naming of Ashish Anchinhar alongside these authors is significant: it places the ghazal movement squarely within the parallel literary tradition rather than as a separate aesthetic development.

Videha's scale of achievement, as documented in its archives, is extraordinary: over 400 published issues by 2026; more than 30,000 pages (approximately one hundred lakh words) of Maithili literature in print and digital form; transcription of over 11,000 Tirhuta manuscripts; publication in four scripts (Devanagari, Tirhuta/Mithilakshar, Braille, and IPA); and a 50,000-word Maithili-English vocabulary database. These figures place Videha among the most significant Maithili literary institutions of any era, not merely of the digital period. While Videha (the long-standing Maithili literary journal) provided institutional memory, it failed to teach Behr or Qaafiyaa. The Anchinhar movement created parallel institutions: online mushairas, digital qaafiyaa dictionaries, and the Ghajalsastram press.

The Parallel Literature Movement's central intellectual argument - that the Sahitya Akademi's canonical history of Maithili literature has systematically marginalised Dalit, women, and non-Brahmin literary traditions - has driven its editorial choices across two decades. By publishing Dalit authors alongside Brahmin authors, folk poetry alongside classical poetry, women's writing alongside men's, oral traditions alongside written literature, and literature from the Terai alongside literature from Bihar, Videha has enacted in practice the "parallel history" of Maithili literature that it advocates in theory. The ghazal revival's location within this institutional context gives it a political and literary dimension that extends beyond the form itself.

The Videha e-journal has published ghazals since its early issues, and the blog Anchinhar Aakhar was closely associated with the Videha network from its inception - the blog itself listing Videha as its institutional home page and Gajendra Thakur as a guiding presence. The Parallel Literature Movement's has also contributed ghazals and rubais to the tradition. His published collection Dhangi Baat Banebaak Daam Agoobaar Pene Chan includes Maithili ghazals and rubais, and his Wikipedia page documents his contribution to the genre within the Videha corpus. Active contributors to Anchinhar Aakhar in recent years include Jagadanand Jha 'Manu,' whose ghazals (published through 2024–26) show the mature form of the Maithili ghazal as it has developed within this tradition.

## Part XIII: Maithili Ghazal as Parallel History - Caste, Form, and Democratic Poetics

The ghazal's encounter with Mithila's caste structure is a microcosm of the larger tensions within the Maithili Parallel Literature Movement. Mithila - with its elaborate Brahminical social order, its Panjika genealogical records, its tradition of Sanskrit scholarship and Navya-Nyaya philosophy - is one of the most rigidly hierarchical social formations in the Indian subcontinent. Literary culture in this context has historically reflected and reinforced these hierarchies: the Maithili canon, as constructed by the Sahitya Akademi and its predecessors, is overwhelmingly the canon of Brahmin male authors writing in a Sanskritic literary register. Historically, formal prosody (chhand-shastra) in Mithila was a Brahminical preserve (Jha, Mishra).

The Nachari, the Padavali, the Maheshvani - the classical Maithili lyric forms - are deeply embedded in Sanskrit aesthetic convention, the Brahmin court culture of Mithila, and the devotional cults of Shaivism and Vaishnavism. Their subject matter (the loves of Radha-Krishna, the marriage of Shiva-Parvati, devotion to the goddess) and their formal conventions (Sanskrit-derived metres, the court bhanita tradition) encode a particular cultural hierarchy. The ghazal, by contrast, enters the Maithili lyric tradition from the cultural world of Urdu - a language historically associated with Muslim patronage, syncretic literary culture, and the urban marketplace rather than the Sanskrit Brahmin academy.

The ghazal, when it arrived in Maithili, was itself initially a high-caste import: poets who could compose correctly in bahr and qafiya needed knowledge of

Urdu prosody, and Urdu education was predominantly available to educated upper-caste men with access to traditional literary networks. The founding figures of the Maithili ghazal - Pandit Jivan Jha, Sitaram Jha, Madhup - were themselves Maithil Brahmins, products of this educational tradition.

The Anchinhar movement's achievement has been to detach the ghazal's formal requirements from this social base by making formal knowledge publicly and freely accessible. The Ghazalsastram - documented on the blog, available to anyone - means that a Dalit poet in Madhubani or an OBC poet in Sitamarhi can learn to compose a correct Maithili ghazal without requiring social access to an upper-caste literary network. By insisting on strict form, it paradoxically broke caste barriers: form became a leveller. Anyone who could master Behr could write; lineage became irrelevant. It made Behr available to non-Brahmin, women, and Dalit poets. The digital medium and the freely available theoretical content collectively function as a social equaliser: they redistribute the cultural capital that formal ghazal knowledge represents.

When Dalit and lower-caste Maithili writers, or writers from the Maithili diaspora in Kolkata and other urban centres, adopt the ghazal form, they are not merely making an aesthetic choice. They are choosing a form whose cultural pedigree sits outside the Brahmin-dominated canon of classical Maithili, thereby signalling their refusal of that canon's exclusive authority. The parallel between this move and the adoption of free verse (muktakakavya) in modern Maithili - itself a challenge to Sanskrit metrical convention - is instructive.

The Anchinhar Aakhar blog's section 'Ghazal ke Iskul' (School of Ghazal) functions as a democratic pedagogical resource: making the formal rules of ghazal accessible to any Maithili writer who wishes to compose in the form, regardless of whether they have the traditional Sanskrit-prosody education that was once the prerequisite for serious Maithili literary composition. This democratisation of formal knowledge - enabled by the internet and the digital presence of Videha and Anchinhar Aakhar - is itself one of the most significant developments in twenty-first-century Maithili literary culture.

This redistribution is, however, partial and ongoing. Access to the internet - while dramatically expanding - is still not universal in the Maithili-speaking region. Literacy in Devanagari (the script of the blog and the eJournal) is higher among urban, educated populations. The oral-performative dimension of ghazal culture - the mushaira - remains predominantly physical, and physical mushairas are still largely organised through social networks with their own hierarchies. The democratic project of the Anchinhar era is real and significant;

it is also incomplete, and its completion will require sustained institutional effort over generations.

# Part XIV: Parallels with Other Indian Language Ghazal Movements

## 14.1 Bengali: The Nazrul Legacy

The Bengali ghazal tradition offers the closest geographical and linguistic parallel to the Maithili case. Bengali and Maithili are sister languages of the Magadhi-Prakrit branch, and the Bengal region shared with Mithila a history of deep engagement with Persian literary culture under the medieval Sultanate of Bengal (1352–1576) - including the famous correspondence between Sultan Ghiyasuddin Azam Shah and Hafiz. Nazrul Islam's achievement in Bengali ghazal writing is particularly instructive: like Ashish Anchinhar, Nazrul brought to his work a deep knowledge of both the classical Urdu ghazal tradition and the native literary and musical culture of his language. He demonstrated that formal correctness and linguistic authenticity are not in tension. Bengali ghazal, though less formally rigorous than some counterparts, was continued in the twentieth century by Shamsur Rahman and others.

## 14.2 Marathi: Suresh Bhat and the Mission of Formal Correctness

Suresh Bhat (1932–2003) occupies in Marathi ghazal history a position analogous in several important respects to Ashish Anchinhar's in Maithili. Both are poets who combined intense creative engagement with the ghazal form with a systematic commitment to demonstrating and maintaining formal standards. Both worked with relative institutional independence, maintaining their commitment to formal correctness against the pressure of a literary environment that might have been content with lesser standards. Both developed a pedagogy - Bhat through his direct correction (islah) of students' work, Anchinhar through the blog's systematic teaching sections. The differences are equally instructive: Bhat worked primarily through print publication and physical mushairas in a Maharashtra with an extensive print literary infrastructure; Anchinhar works primarily through digital media. This comparison suggests that the Maithili ghazal's digital-first character is a response to linguistic-community conditions, not merely a preference.

## 14.3 Hindi: Dushyant Kumar and the Political Ghazal

Dushyant Kumar (1931–1975) transformed the Hindi ghazal from an imitative echo of Urdu practice into an original and politically powerful literary form. His achievement - building a bridge between Urdu and Hindi ghazal by demonstrating that the form could be written in a Hindavi idiom accessible to Hindi speakers without Urdu literary training - is a feat of cultural diplomacy as much as literary artistry. The Hindi ghazal's encounter with the Hindi-Urdu divide adds a dimension absent from the Maithili case. Adil Mansuri and Bashir Badr developed the tradition further.

## 14.4 What Makes the Maithili Case Distinctive

What distinguishes the Maithili ghazal movement from its counterparts in larger Indian languages is its connection to the Parallel Literature Movement. In Hindi, the ghazal revival was primarily an aesthetic-nationalist project; in Maithili, it is simultaneously a formal experiment, a democratic cultural assertion, and a reclamation of the cross-cultural history of Mithila that the dominant Brahmin-Sanskrit literary canon had suppressed. The Maithili ghazal is not simply a new form in an old language - it is a form through which the language's suppressed histories (of Muslim cultural influence, of lower-caste creativity, of diaspora experience) find their literary expression.

Chaudhary's survey of Maithili literature, written in 1976 and updated for the 2010 edition, does not discuss the ghazal. Its silence is historically understandable - the Maithili ghazal movement had not yet taken its current shape - but it is also symptomatic of the classical survey's blind spots. Any comprehensive parallel history of Maithili literature in the twenty-first century must include the ghazal revival as one of the most intellectually and culturally significant developments of the post-Eighth Schedule era.

Comparative summary across Indian regional ghazal traditions:

| Language | Movement / Key Figure | Parallel to Maithili (Anchinhar Era) |
|---|---|---|
| Bengali | Kazi Nazrul Islam; Atul Prasad Sen | Closest linguistic parallel (Magadhi-Prakrit branch); shared medieval Bengal Sultanate Persian |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | | influence; Nazrul maintained bahr discipline and Bengali authenticity simultaneously - same dual achievement as Anchinhar. Shamsur Rahman also contributed to revival. Less systematic theoretical codification. |
| Gujarati | Sher-O-Shaayari; Asim Randeri; Barkat Virani "Befaam" | Similar borrowing from Urdu; close ties to mushaira culture and Bohra/Khoja Muslim communities. Lacks a systematic Ghazalsastram equivalent. |
| Marathi | Suresh Bhat, "Ghazal Samrat" (1932–2003) | Strongest structural parallel: Bhat combined creative engagement with formal pedagogy and institutional independence, as Anchinhar does. Six major collections, 260 ghazals. Strong feminist/Ambedkarite thread; Buddhist conversion; mass cultural reach via Lata Mangeshkar recordings. Lacked digital Wikipedia archiving. Worked primarily through print; larger linguistic community. |
| Hindi | Dushyant Kumar (Saaye Mein Dhoop, 1975) | Transformed ghazal into vehicle for political satire and social outrage; navigated Hindi-Urdu ideological divide. Political use of form parallels Anchinhar's anti-caste democratic poetics. Pioneer: Adil Mansuri, Bashir Badr, others continued. |
| Malayalam | Arabi-Malayalam tradition | Hybrid metrical systems in Dravidian phonological context. No |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | | parallel to Bal or Bhakti ghazal sub-genres; less formal theoretical documentation. |
| Telugu | Ghazal Srinivas | Most radical linguistic transplant (Dravidian); required substantial theoretical innovation to accommodate bahr system to agglutinative morphology. |
| Maithili (Anchinhar) | Ghazalsastram & Digital Revival | UNIQUE distinctions: (1) First regional Indian language to codify ghazal grammar into a Sastram. (2) First to create Bal (Children's) ghazals as a formal sub-genre. (3) First to use Wikipedia systematically for revival and prevention of historical erasure. (4) First to reconverge ghazal with drama (2026). (5) Deepest documented correct historical lineage. (6) Explicit embedding within counter-canonical democratic political project. |

## Conclusion

The history traced in this chapter is a history of loss and recovery, erasure and reassertion, marginalisation and democratic renaissance. The Maithili Ghazal presents a unique case study in literary revival. Born correctly (Jeevan Jha), corrupted by weak poets who erased grammarians like Vijaynath Jha and Yoganand Heera, it was revived not by nostalgia but by structural theory (Ghajalsastram), digital archiving (Wikipedia), and genre expansion (Bal/Bhakti). The Maithili ghazal - historically associated with upper-caste literary culture - is being simultaneously recovered (in its formal correctness) and democratised (in its social reach) through the Anchinhar-Videha collaboration. This dual project - recovery and democratisation - reflects the movement's broader understanding that formal excellence and social justice are

not competing values but complementary ones: only a formally correct ghazal is a real ghazal, and only a socially democratic literary culture is a real literary culture.

The recovery has been more than a restoration of the past. The Anchinhar era has added to the tradition: new sub-genres (Bal ghazal, Bhakti ghazal), new theoretical frameworks (Ghazalsastram, new Maithili bahars named after Maithili literary icons), new pedagogical innovations (the numerical matrakram notation, the blog-based ghazal school, bahr analysis through Hindi film songs), new institutional collaborations (Wikipedia, Videha, the online mushaira), and a new democratic social base (extended through the digital medium to poets of all castes, both sexes, and multiple geographical communities). Led by Ashish Anchinhar, the movement has not only restored classical Behr and Qaafiyaa but has also used strict form as a tool for democratic, anti-caste poetics.

The 2026 reconvergence with drama marks the formal closure of a century-long divergence, establishing the Maithili Ghazal as a mature, independent, and theoretically robust literary system. The 2026 moment - marked by the reconvergence of the ghazal and Maithili drama - completes one arc of this history and begins another. The form has demonstrated its formal legitimacy (it can be written correctly in Maithili), its emotional authenticity (it speaks to Maithili listeners and readers in a voice that feels native), its theoretical rigour (it has a systematic prosodic foundation), and its social reach (it extends through the digital platform to Maithili speakers everywhere).

The description of Ashish Anchinhar as "the other name of Maithili ghazal" reflects a historical truth of the present moment. One hopes - and the institutional infrastructure that the movement has built makes it possible to hope - that the next generation of Maithili ghazalkars will make that description obsolete, not by superseding Anchinhar but by building on his work a tradition so rich, so diverse, and so formally accomplished that no single name can stand for the whole.

STOP PRESS:

The Catalyst: Similar to how the Protestant movement acted as a disruptor for traditional religious institutions, parallel literature movements are now challenging the literary establishment.

The Reaction: The Sahitya Akademi is being portrayed as a conservative body forced into a "Counter-Reformation" of sorts—adapting its focus to include formal structures like Bahar (Chhand) that it may have previously overlooked.

**Ashish Anchinhar [Videha Sadeha 23]**

**A Maithili Ghazal that Changed the History of Maithili Music**

Every influence in society affects another (though imitation cannot be called true influence). These influences can be both positive and negative. Literature is a product of society, as are its various genres. It is common for a great work in one genre to be inspired by another. Similarly, a work is often transformed from one genre into another; this is a healthy process. However, the crucial point is that the audience should be aware of this. For example, the dramatic adaptation of Madhup Ji's poem *'Ghasal Atthanni'* exists, but it is always advertised beforehand as a play based on his poem.

Unfortunately, this "Maithili Ghazal" never received such fair treatment. It is a work that **"changed the history of Maithili music,"** yet writers and musicians have not done it justice. It is a *Ghazal*, yet it is promoted as a *Geet* (song). What could be sadder for a literary genre?

I am not saying this for the common people. I understand that when a great work becomes popular, words get shuffled and genres are overlooked. My complaint is against the so-called scholars and those who call themselves "great singers" for failing this Ghazal. For nearly 90 years, readers and listeners have been misled, even though the composition follows the grammar of a Ghazal. Even though the creator identified it as a Ghazal, this is the current state of affairs.

The influence of this Ghazal is so vast that every singer who performed it either sang it incorrectly or created parodies based on it. There are three reasons for this:

1. **The Weakness of Modern Maithili Song Genre:** In the modern era, the *Geet* genre lost its definitive foundation in Maithili. The lyricists are responsible for this—those who considered any rhyming lines a "song" and were more interested in being honored on stage with a *Paag* (traditional headgear). To this day, the Maithili song genre lacks its own critics.
2. **The Lack of Knowledge:** Alleged *Ghazalkars* in Maithili have often acted as "sycophants." Wherever they saw a stage, they sought a meal, yet their knowledge of Ghazal grammar remained zero. How could they recognize this work as a Ghazal?
3. **The Overwhelming Influence:** If we speak of the influence of any work after Vidyapati's songs, this Ghazal's name would be at the top.

   I am not here to discuss the song genre, but to clear the confusion spread over 90 years by "weak lyricists" and "weak singers." Many singers claim they composed based on a "vibe" (*bhaas*). But I ask: which vibe? The very vibe that belongs to this Ghazal. They take the words of this Ghazal, shuffle them, and sing them incorrectly.

   Kavivar Sitaram Jha's *Suktisudha* (First Point) was first published in 1928. In this collection, the poet presented one of his compositions specifically as a Ghazal, which I am providing below:

   *Jagat me thaki Jagdambe ahink path aabi baisal chhi Hamar kyau ne sunaiye ham sabhak gun gaabi baisal chhi*

*Na kailon dharm seva wa na devaradhane kaukhan Kuteba mein chhalon lagal takar phal paabi baisal chhi*

*Daya swatik ghanmala jakan apnek bhutal mein Lagaune aas ham chatak jakan munh baabi baisal chhi*

*Kahu ki Amba apne san phuraiye baat ne kichhuo Apan aparadh san chupki laga jee daabi baisal chhi*

*Karai yadi dosh balak tan na ho man rokh mata kain Ahin vishwas kain keval hriday mein laabi baisal chhi*

The above composition is a Ghazal, written in Sitaram Ji's own orthography. Singers consistently sing this incorrectly. I have detailed the grammar of this Ghazal in my book, *'The Grammar and History of Maithili Ghazal.'* Many call this a *Bhagwati Geet*, whereas it should be called a **'Bhagwati Ghazal.'** It is the pride of the "Anchinhar Akhar" team to have coined the term **'Bhakti Ghazal'** (Devotional Ghazal) in Maithili (by Amit Mishra on August 7, 2012). Thus, Kavivar Sitaram Jha is the first writer of the 'Bhakti Ghazal' in Maithili.

Regarding the "vibe" mentioned earlier: because this Ghazal is nearly 100 years old (8 years to go), its structure has become a "cult" classic. People now use its meter for parodies and stubbornly claim they aren't copying. I suspect this Ghazal faded from the sight of many, including Dr. Ramdev Jha, who cited other Ghazals by Sitaram Jha in a 1984 article but missed this devotional one.

A list of some renditions that distorted the original or turned it into a parody (including both amateurs and famous names):

1. **Neelkamal Jha:** Got the author's name wrong and shuffled the original words. He credited Upendra Thakur 'Mohan' as the lyricist, which is objectionable.
2. **Sanjay Jha:** Sang based on the meter/vibe.
3. **Maithili Thakur:** Shuffled and altered the original words in her rendition.
4. **Aditya Nath:** Created a parody.
5. **Bhavya Rani:** Shuffled the original words.
6. **Uma Jha:** Shuffled the original words.
7. **Premsagar:** Created a "third-class" parody.

**Pradeep Pushpa Ji** is an exception; though not a professional singer, he posted a correct recitation of the Ghazal on Facebook.

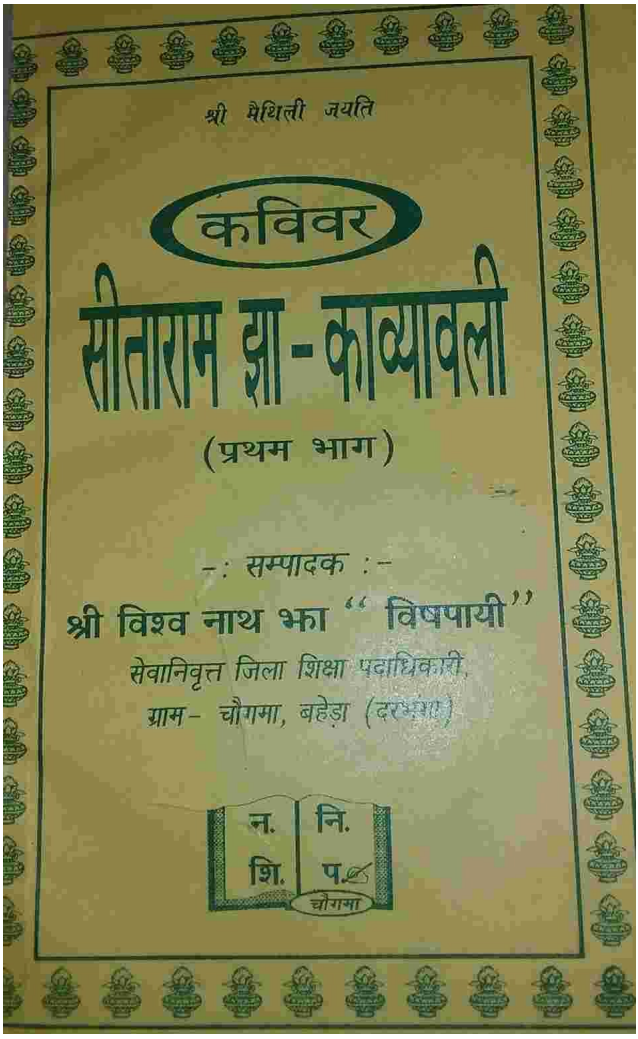
It is clear that Sitaram Ji's Ghazal deeply permeated the song genre. Several factors are responsible: the *Beher* (meter) and *Kaafiya* (rhyme), the *Shakta*

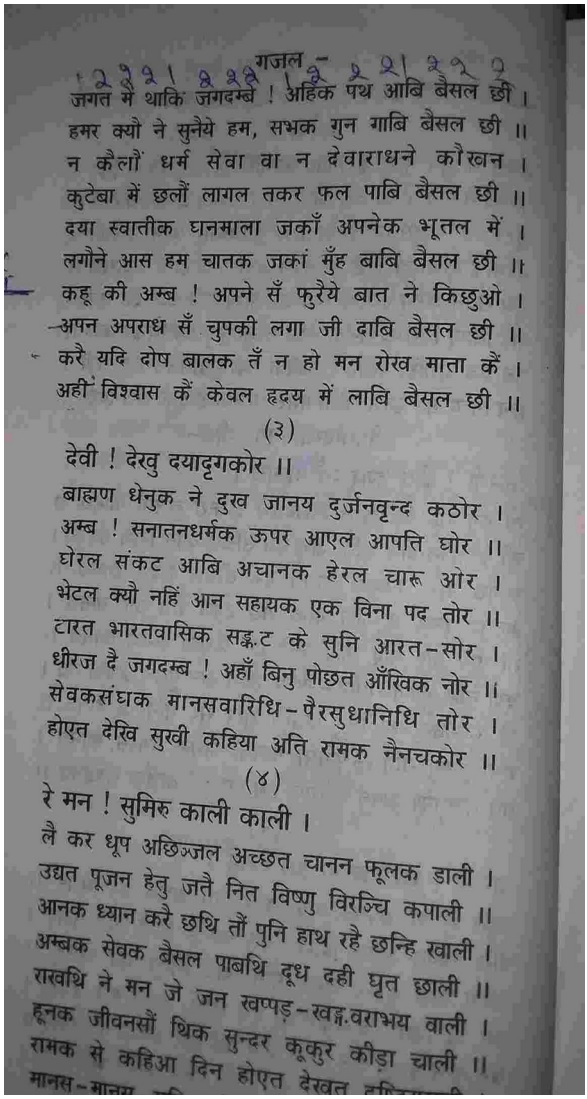
tradition of Mithila, and the simple vocabulary. Its success lies in the fact that it reached the heights of a popular song while remaining a Ghazal.

It is now our duty—out of respect for the author and the genre—to ensure this work is sung with the correct lyrics, identified by its correct genre, and credited to the rightful creator. Otherwise, the Ghazal genre is no longer "weak"; it knows how to claim its rightful place.

I urge all "Ghazal activists" to struggle for the proper recognition of Kavivar Ji and his Ghazal. We must comment on these platforms to correct the genre and the creator's name. I have already started by commenting on Neelkamal Jha’s link.

(Photos below)


श्री मैथिली जयति
कविवर
सीताराम झा - काव्यावली
(प्रथम भाग)
-: सम्पादक :-
श्री विश्व नाथ झा "विषपायी"
सेवानिवृत्त जिला शिक्षा पदाधिकारी,
ग्राम- चौगमा, बहेड़ा (दरभंगा)
न. नि.
शि. प.
चौगमा



गजल -

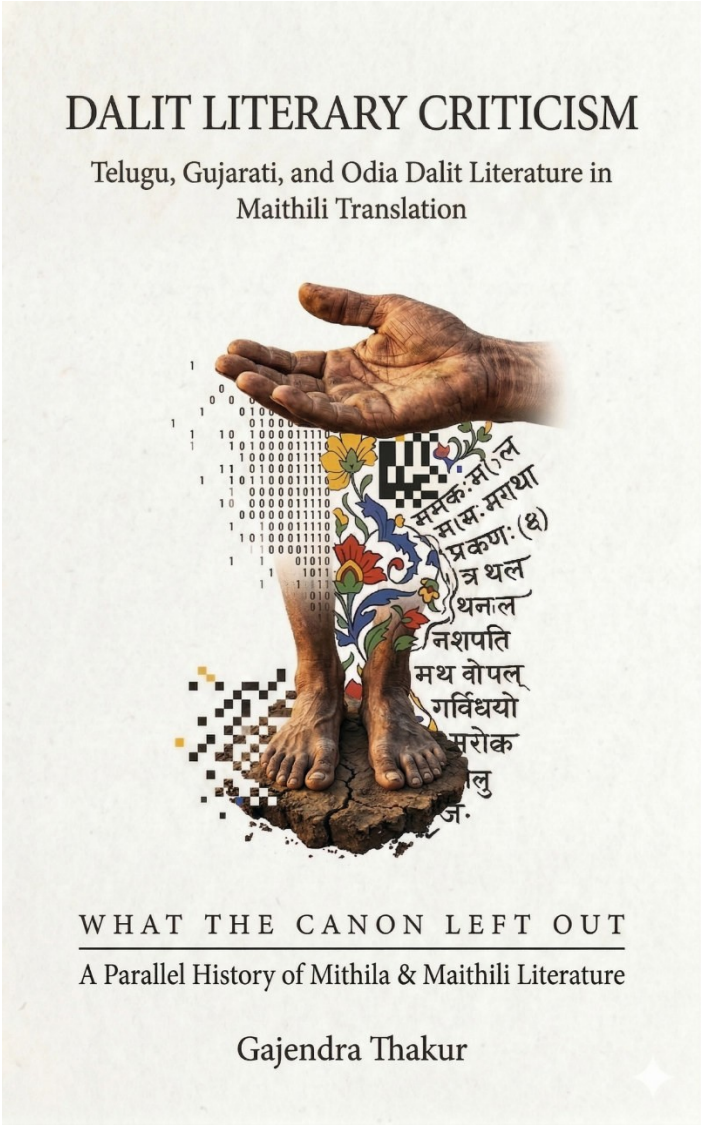
जगत में थाकि जगदम्ब ! अहिंक पथ आबि बैसल छी ।
हमर क्यो ने सुनेये हम, सभक गुन गाबि बैसल छी ॥
न कैलौं धर्म सेवा वा न देवाराधने कौखन ।
कुटेबा में छलौं लागल तकर फल पाबि बैसल छी ॥
दया स्वातीक घनमाला जकाँ अपनेक भूतल में ।
लगोने आस हम चातक जकां मुँह बाबि बैसल छी ॥
कहू की अम्ब ! अपने सँ फुरैये बात ने किछुओ ।
अपन अपराध सँ चुपकी लगा जी दाबि बैसल छी ॥
करै यदि दोष बालक तँ न हो मन रोख माता कैं ।
अही विश्वास कैं केवल हृदय में लाबि बैसल छी ॥

(३)

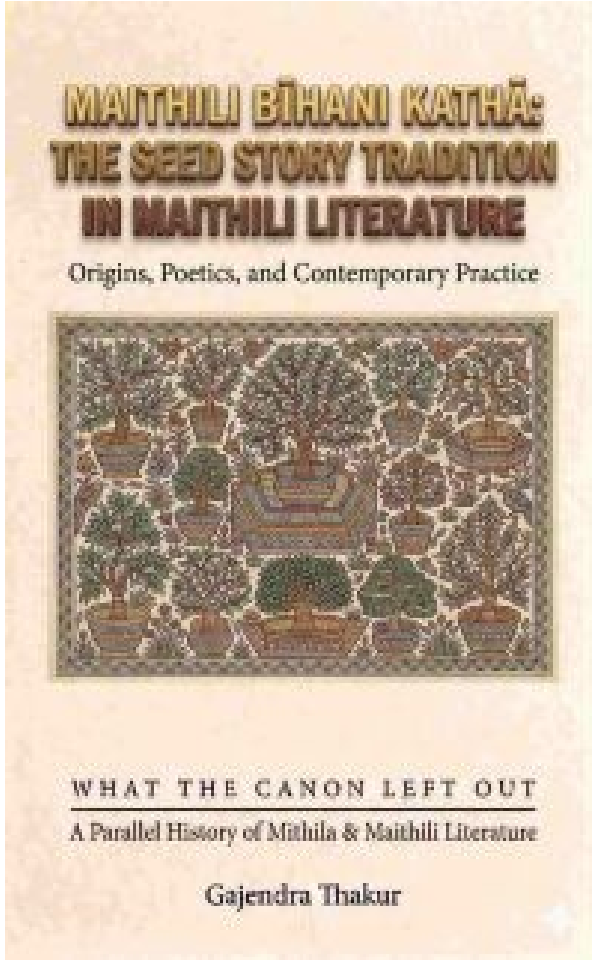
देवी ! देखु दयादृगकोर ॥
ब्राह्मण धेनुक ने दुख जानय दुर्जनवृन्द कठोर ।
अम्ब ! सनातनधर्मक ऊपर आएल आपति घोर ॥
घोरल संकट आबि अचानक हेरल चारू ओर ।
भेटल क्यो नहिं आन सहायक एक विना पद तोर ॥
टारत भारतवासिक सङ्कट के सुनि आरत-सोर ।
धीरज दै जगदम्ब ! अहाँ बिनु पोछत आँखिक नोर ॥
सेवकसंघक मानसवारिधि-पैरसुधानिधि तोर ।
होएत देखि सुखी कहिया अति रामक नैनचकोर ॥

(४)

रे मन ! सुमिरु काली काली ।
लै कर धूप अछिञ्जल अच्छत चानन फूलक डाली ।
उद्यत पूजन हेतु जतै नित विष्णु विरञ्चि कपाली ॥
आनक ध्यान करै छथि तौं पुनि हाथ रहै छन्हि खाली ।
अम्बक सेवक बैसल पाबथि दूध दही घृत छाली ॥
राखथि ने मन जे जन खप्पड़-खड्ग.वराभय वाली ।
हूनक जीवनसौं थिक सुन्दर कूकुर कीड़ा चाली ॥
रामक से कहिआ दिन होएत देखत [illegible]
मानस-मानस [illegible]


DALIT LITERARY CRITICISM
Telugu, Gujarati, and Odia Dalit Literature in Maithili Translation
WHAT THE CANON LEFT OUT
A Parallel History of Mithila & Maithili Literature
Gajendra Thakur

LESSON 004 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY




# Maithili Bīhani Kathā

## The Seed Story Tradition in Maithili Literature:

### *Origins, Poetics, and Contemporary Practice*

The Maithili bīhani kathā literally the 'seed story' or 'very short story' is a micronarrative form unique to Maithili literature that has no direct equivalent in other Indian literary languages. Distinct from the lagnukathā (shortshort story) and bearing only a superficial kinship with the Hindi laprek, the bīhani kathā is a form that distils an entire narrative, emotional universe, and thematic weight

into a very brief compass, typically under 300 words and often considerably shorter. This chapter traces the etymology, formal definition, genealogy, and contemporary flourishing of the bīhani kathā. It draws on the archive of Videha the first Maithili fortnightly eJournal (ISSN 2229547X, videha.co.in) including the landmark anthology Videha Maithili Vihani Kathā (Videha Sadeha 5), the critical writings of Munnaji, the scholarship of Bijayendra Jha, and the wider creative and editorial infrastructure of the Parallel Literature Movement. The chapter argues that the bīhani kathā is not simply a compressed short story but a genetically distinct form shaped by Maithili oral tradition, the pragmatics of digital dissemination, and the ideological commitments of democratic and subaltern literary practice.

## 1. Introduction: A Form Without a Twin

Among the several contributions of the Maithili Parallel Literature Movement the democratic literary tendency championed most visibly by Videha eJournal and the galaxy of writers associated with it the bīhani kathā ('seed story' or 'very short story') occupies a singular position. It is a narrative form that the Maithili literary tradition has nurtured as its own distinctive property rather than as an importation from any other literary culture.

The very name bīhani (also spelledvihani) is instructive. In standard Maithili, bīhani / bīhaṇi means 'seed' the grain placed in earth at planting time, the smallest unit from which an entire plant may grow. As a literarycritical term it signals that the form aspires to the condition of the seed: complete in itself, selfcontained, yet carrying within its brevity the potential fullness of a much larger narrative. The metaphor is apt. A good bīhani kathā is not a truncated story; it is a story that has concentrated rather than abbreviated itself.

The term stands in contrast to the laprek, a parallel microfiction form that has circulated in Hindi and has sometimes been imported into Maithili writing. As the critic Bijayendra Jha has observed in his 2025 article 'A Critical Analysis of Maithili Short Stories: Twenty First Century', the laprek derives from outside the Maithili literary tradition, whereas the bīhani kathā is Maithili's own. This distinction is not merely etymological; it has implications for form, theme, readership, and the politics of literary autonomy.

This chapter maps the bīhani kathā from four angles: its etymological and formal definition; its literaryhistorical antecedents within Maithili tradition; the development of a distinct poetics through the critical writings of Munnaji and

the editorial practice of Videha; and the contemporary landscape of bīhani kathā authorship in the twentyfirst century.

So far as verse is concerned apart from Haiku/ Senryu/ Tanka, Kshanika or Naneelu [Naneelu is a form of Telugu literature (N. Gopi introduced it) which contains 4 lines and a minimum of 20 letters and a maximum of 25]. Original Nannelu is also available, as Maithili translation, in Videha eJournal.

# 2. Etymology, Terminology, and Orthography

## 2.1 The Word bīhani / vihani

The Maithili word bīhani (Devanagari: बीहनि; Tirhuta/Mithilakshar: 𑒩𑒻𑒲𑒨𑒹) derives from a root associated with seedgrain or morning its use in Maithili folk idiom for the first seed of a crop cycle gives it connotations of origination and potentiality. Several orthographic variants appear in the journal and critical literature: bīhani, vihani, beehaṇi. The Videha archive uses both bīhani and vihani in different periods; vihani appears on the cover of Videha Sadeha 5 (the major anthology, discussed below), while bīhani appears in Gajendra Thakur's own creative and critical work such as the 2023 collection Parvat Ūpar Bhamarā Je Sūtal (बीहनि, लघु आ दीर्घ कथा संग्रह). Both spellings are current in the field.

## 2.2 Distinctions Within the Short Prose Spectrum

Maithili critical vocabulary distinguishes at least three strata of short prose narrative:

(1) Kathā / Laghu Kathā the standard short story, broadly comparable to the short story tradition in other Indian languages. Maithili short story criticism from the late twentieth and twentyfirst centuries largely applies to this form.

(2) Lagnukathā the shortshort story or flash fiction; somewhat analogous to the Hindi laghukathā, though with distinct Maithili inflections.

(3) Bīhani Kathā / Vihani Kathā the seed story or very short story, which in Maithili represents a formally distinct mode rather than simply a quantitative reduction of the short story. In practice a bīhani kathā may be as short as a single compact paragraph, almost always under 300 words, and typically

characterized by a compressed arc, symbolic density, and what we might call 'seed logic' an ending that opens rather than closes meaning.

The laprek, which also circulates in the Maithili field, is understood in Maithili criticism as an imported form. Its name derives from the Hindi acronym or coinage laghu prem kathā (short love story), and while Maithili writers do compose in this mode, the critical consensus articulated by Bijayendra Jha among others reserves bīhani kathā as the distinctly Maithili designation. The two forms may overlap in length but differ in genealogy, thematic range (the bīhani kathā is not restricted to love themes), and formal aspiration.

# 3. LiteraryHistorical Antecedents

## 3.1 Oral Narrative and the Economy of the Maithil Tale

Maithili has a rich tradition of oral narrative that prizes compression and wit. The Dhūrta Samāgama attributed to Jyotirishwar Thakur (c. 1290-1350 CE) arguably the earliest prose work in any north Indian vernacular already shows a delight in brief, pointed narrative episodes and rhetorical reversals that find their distant descendants in the modern bīhani kathā. Similarly, the Dāka Vachan (proverbial sayings attributed to the legendary seer Dāk) cultivated the compressed utterance as its primary vehicle for social and philosophical insight.

The oral storytelling practised at Maithil domestic gatherings particularly the tradition of women's narrative at festivals and lifecycle rituals habitually employed very brief embedded tales as a mode of ethical and social commentary. These are not the same as bīhani kathā in the modern literary sense, but they constitute a cultural preformation of the appetite for brief, complete, meaningful narrative units.

## 3.2 The Modern Short Story and Its Acceleration

The written Maithili short story (kathā) is conventionally traced to Shrikrishna Singh's Chandraprabha (1855), though the form developed more robustly from the late nineteenth century onward under the influence of journals, anthologies, and the broader social reform movements that shaped literary production in Mithila. The twentieth century saw a rapid expansion of the short story tradition, with particular efflorescence from the 1960s onward.

By the opening decades of the twentyfirst century, more than 300 Maithili story collections had been published, and seven collections had received Sahitya

Akademi recognition among them Neerja Renu's Ritambhara (2003), Vibhuti Anand's Kath (2006), Pradeep Bihari's Sarokar (2007), Manmohan Jha's Gangaputra (2009) and Khissa (2015), Shyam Darihare's Badki Kaki Etā Hot Mail Dot Com (2016), and Veena Thakur's Parineeta (2018). This proliferation created both an incentive and a formal pressure: writers began to experiment with ever more compressed forms as readers in a fastpaced digital world sought complete aesthetic experiences available in a single sitting.

It is precisely in this context that the bīhani kathā crystallized as a distinct genre with a distinct name, a distinct critical vocabulary, and ultimately a dedicated anthology.

# 4. Videha and the Institutionalization of the Bīhani Kathā

## 4.1 Videha eJournal: Platform and Politics

Videha (videha.co.in; ISSN 2229547X), the first Maithili fortnightly eJournal, has been the principal institutional home of the bīhani kathā since its inception around 2000. Edited by Gajendra Thakur, Videha is aligned with what its editor calls the Parallel Literature Movement a conscious counterproject to the Sahitya Akademi establishment and the dominantcaste gatekeeping that has historically controlled access to Maithili print publication. Videha has published over 400 issues and maintains a freely downloadable archive of the entire journal run as well as a separate archive of Maithili books (videha.co.in/pothi.htm).

By providing a free, noncommercial digital platform with no print gatekeepers, Videha enabled a far wider range of voices from Dalit writers to women writers, from Nepalbased Maithili authors to diaspora contributors to publish and circulate bīhani kathā. The short, completeinitself nature of the form made it ideal for the fortnightly eJournal format: a bīhani kathā could be published, read, discussed, and responded to within a single issue cycle.

As noted by Mithilesh Kumar Jha in the India Seminar, Videha provided a platform to notable emerging writers including Jagadish Prasad Mandal, Rajdeo Mandal, Umesh Paswan, Munnaji, Ashish Anchinhar, and Chandan Kumar Jha, and systematically countered 'the usurpation of Maithili and its legitimate representation by a few dominant castes in Mithila.'

### 4.2 Videha Sadeha 5: The Canonical Anthology

The landmark institutional moment in the bīhani kathā's emergence as a recognized genre is the publication of Videha Maithili Vihani Kathā (Videha Sadeha 5), edited by Gajendra Thakur and available for download from the Videha archive. This anthology published in both Devanagari and Tirhuta/Mithilakshar editions collects the finest bīhani kathā from across the journal's run up to the point of compilation, providing both a corpus and a critical statement about the form's autonomy. A second revised edition (Videha Sadeha 5, Sankskarana 2) was subsequently also made available, attesting to the demand for the anthology.

The very existence of the anthology separately titled and separately numbered within the Sadeha series signals that the bīhani kathā had achieved sufficient critical mass and formal distinctness to merit standalone treatment, distinguishing it from the adjacent Videha Maithili Laghu Kathā anthology (Videha Sadeha 6) devoted to shortshort stories. This bibliographic articulation is itself a critical act.

### 4.3 Sagar Rati Dīp Jaray and the OralPerformance Dimension

The Sagar Rati Dīp Jaray the allnight Maithili literary festival and performance tradition associated with Videha has periodically been organized around the bīhani kathā and laghu kathā as its central genre. The 83rd Sagar Rati Dīp Jaray, organized by Nanda Vilas Ray at Bhapṭiyāhī, was specifically convened as a womencentred laghu and vihani kathā event, running from evening of 30 August to dawn of 31 August. This connects the written bīhani kathā back to the oral performance tradition while simultaneously giving the form a feminist and subaltern inflection: the allnight festival format, with its connotations of vigil and collective literary witness, treats the micronarrative not as a minor form but as a genre worthy of sustained communal attention.

## 5. The Poetics of the Bīhani Kathā: Munnaji's Contribution

### 5.1 Munnaji as Critic and Practitioner

Munnaji a significant figure in Videhaaffiliated Maithili writing occupies a dual role as both practitioner and critical theorist of the bīhani kathā. Her creative

contributions include 'Pratik' (2012), cited by Bijayendra Jha as one of the important bīhani kathā of the second decade of the twentyfirst century. Her critical writings, published in and around Videha, articulate what might be called a poetics of the form a set of principles that distinguish the bīhani kathā from adjacent forms and provide criteria for its evaluation.

## 5.2 Principles of Bīhani Kathā Poetics (derived from Munnaji's critical practice)

From Munnaji's criticism and from the editorial practice of Videha, the following principles of bīhani kathā poetics can be reconstructed:

Completeness: A bīhani kathā is not a fragment or sketch but a complete narrative arc, however compressed. Even if the ending is open or ironic, the form achieves closure at the level of emotional or thematic meaning. This distinguishes it from the mere anecdote or vignette.

Seed Logic (bīhani tarka): Like a seed, the bīhani kathā contains within itself more than it overtly shows. The prose surface is minimal; the narrative potential is maximal. What is unsaid the silence beneath the said is formally constitutive of the form rather than a deficiency.

Single Strike: The best bīhani kathā achieves its effect in a single reading, at a single sitting, with a single concentrated impact. This is the Maithili equivalent of what Poe called the 'single effect' in short story theory, but more extreme: the bīhani kathā seeks not merely unified effect but instantaneous effect.

Social Pointedness: Unlike the laprek which has an amorous bias built into its very name the bīhani kathā is thematically unrestricted. In practice, however, the Videhapublished bīhani kathā shows a strong tendency toward social critique, gender consciousness, Dalit and subaltern experience, and the ironies of modernity in rural Mithila. This thematic orientation reflects Videha's broader politicalliterary commitments.

Linguistic Authenticity: Munnaji's critical writing is alert to the question of linguistic authenticity the difference between authentic Maithili prose and Hindiinflected Maithili. The bīhani kathā, as a form cultivated by the Parallel Literature Movement, is expected to embody genuine Maithili linguistic identity rather than the sanskritized or hindiized register that the dominantcaste literary establishment has sometimes privileged.

# 6. Major Practitioners and Works

## 6.1 Gajendra Thakur

As editor and primary architect of the Videha archive, Gajendra Thakur has written original bīhani kathā in addition to compiling and editing the genre's canonical anthology. His 2009 collection GalpaGucchha (विहनि आ लघु कथा संग्रह) is one of the earliest singleauthor collections explicitly to frame its contents as vihani and laghu kathā. His 2023 collection Parvat Ūpar Bhamarā Je Sūtal (पर्वत ऊपर भमरा जे सूतल बीहनि, लघु आ दीर्घ कथा संग्रह) places bīhani kathā in dialogue with short and long fiction within a single volume, demonstrating the formal range available to a writer who moves fluently across the Maithili prose spectrum.

## 6.2 Munnaji

Munnaji's 'Pratik' (2012) is repeatedly cited in surveys of twentyfirstcentury Maithili microfiction as a landmark work of the bīhani kathā form. Her critical essays on the form have provided theoretical scaffolding for the genre's selfunderstanding. As both writer and critic she represents a pattern common in the Videha literary world: the creative practitioner who is also the critic of the practice, developing theory from inside the work rather than imposing it from without.

## 6.3 Jagadish Prasad Mandal

Among the most prolific Maithili fiction writers of any era, Jagadish Prasad Mandal has published more than fifty story collections. His work has consistently centred the Dalit and lowercaste experience of Mithila the social margins that the Sahitya Akademi establishment has historically neglected. His bīhani kathā 'BajantaBujhanta' (2023) is among the cited examples of recent work in the form. Mandal's presence in the bīhani kathā tradition is crucial: his work anchors the form's ideological centre of gravity in subaltern experience rather than brahminical sentiment.

## 6.4 Other Significant Contributors

Bijayendra Jha's 2025 survey identifies several important twentyfirstcentury bīhani kathā. Beyond those already mentioned, the canon includes: Kapileswar

Raut's 'Ulahan'; Jagadanand Jha's 'Tohar Katek Rang'; Sujit Kumar Jha's 'Koili Ghuri Aao'; Anamol Jha's 'Samaya Sakshi Thik'; Ramvilas Sahu's 'Iskulak Khichari'; Rajdev Mandal's 'Trivenik Rang'; and Ghanashyam Ghanero's contributions. Each of these writers brings a distinct social location, thematic preoccupation, and stylistic signature to the form, demonstrating its capacity to absorb varied creative voices while maintaining its generic identity.

The womencentred Sagar Rati Dīp Jaray mentioned above suggests a special vitality of women's participation in the bīhani kathā tradition a trend consistent with Videha's sustained attention to the Stri Kona (Women's Corner) and to the literary contributions of women across caste and class lines.

## 7. The Bīhani Kathā and the Laprek: A Necessary Distinction

The relationship between the bīhani kathā and the laprek deserves its own sustained attention because the two forms are frequently confused in popular discussion, and because the distinction matters both critically and politically.

The laprek is a Hindiorigin form; its very name encodes the amorous ('prem') as the genre's defining theme. It circulates as a kind of popular internet microfiction, widely shared on social media, and has been extensively imitated in Maithili as well. Several writers associated with Videha have composed what might be described as laprekstyle work: Mithilesh Kumar Jha's 'Tisa'; Anamol Jha's 'Technology' and 'E Je Samaya Achhi'; Bibhuti Anand's 'Iss' and 'Bhak'; Gyanvardhan Kanth's 'Kakiya'; and others. However, the critical tradition associated with Munnaji and Bijayendra Jha is careful to assign these to the laprek category (imported form) rather than the bīhani kathā category (indigenous Maithili form), even when the works are otherwise excellent.

The bīhani kathā, by contrast, is theorized as emerging from within Maithili literary culture from its oral traditions, its folknarrative economy, its aesthetic of the compressed and the pointed rather than as an adaptation of an imported popular form. This is not a chauvinistic assertion but a claim about genealogy and formal possibility: the bīhani kathā can and does address the full range of Maithili social experience rather than being constrained by the laprek's amorous template.

The distinction also reflects Videha's broader political project: the assertion of Maithili literary autonomy against both Hindi cultural hegemony and the

tendency to define Maithili literature as derivative of or subordinate to panIndian (read: Hindidominated) literary forms.

# 8. The Digital Ecology of the Bīhani Kathā

The bīhani kathā is in significant ways a form adapted to the digital age. Its brevity makes it shareable; its completeness makes it satisfying in the attention economy; its free digital availability (through Videha) makes it accessible to readers who cannot or do not purchase print books. Videha's commitment to maintaining a freely downloadable archive all issues in PDF, available in multiple scripts (Devanagari, Tirhuta, Kaithi) has been essential to the form's wide circulation.

The Videha Maithili Vihani Kathā anthology (Videha Sadeha 5) is available in both Devanagari and Tirhuta versions from archive.org, and a second revised edition has also been released suggesting significant demand from both the scholarly and general reader communities. The archive.org platform gives global access: the Maithili diaspora in other Indian states, in Nepal, and abroad can access the bīhani kathā in the same moment as readers in Darbhanga or Madhubani.

The fortnightly publication rhythm of Videha an issue every two weeks also suits the bīhani kathā. New work appears regularly; authors receive prompt feedback from the engaged readership; and the form's brief compass means that a single issue can feature multiple bīhani kathā alongside poetry, longer fiction, criticism, and translation. This generic promiscuity the coexistence of microfiction with longer forms in the same publication works against the marginalization of the short form that sometimes occurs when it is ghettoized into specialist anthologies.

# 9. Thematic Cartography

## 9.1 Social Realism and Subaltern Experience

A significant strand of Maithili bīhani kathā takes as its subject matter the lived experience of the social margins Dalit characters, landless labourers, women in patriarchal households, migrant workers from Mithila. This thematic orientation reflects the Videha movement's commitment to what the Parallel Literature framework calls 'democratic literature' writing that centres those excluded from the canonical tradition. Jagadish Prasad Mandal's bīhani kathā

are particularly notable in this regard: his 'BajantaBujhanta' (2023), like much of his fiction, focuses on lowercaste economic and social conditions with unsentimental directness.

### 9.2 Gender and the Female Voice

Women's writing and women's experience occupy significant space in the Videha bīhani kathā tradition. The allwomencentred Sagar Rati Dīp Jaray formats, the Stri Kona section of Videha, and writers like Munnaji herself indicate a sustained feminist inflection within the form. The bīhani kathā's extreme compression makes it particularly suited to the pointed, ironic mode that feminist social critique often requires: a single gesture or image can carry the weight of an entire argument about gender relations.

### 9.3 Mithila's Modernity

Another major thematic current addresses the tension between the traditional Maithil social world and the forces of modernity migration, caste reform, globalization, digitization. Anamol Jha's laprek/bīhani work 'Technology' and 'E Je Samaya Achhi' (while classified by critics as laprek) gesture toward this territory; other bīhani kathā writers address it more squarely. The disappearance of Tirhuta script from everyday life, the feminization of agricultural labour as men migrate, the irruption of mobile phones into domestic relationships these are characteristic subjects.

### 9.4 Psychological Compression

A number of twentyfirstcentury Maithili microfictions achieve what Bijayendra Jha describes as 'psychological analysis as a separate genre' short fictions so interiorfocused that their narrative arc is essentially a movement of consciousness. This strand connects the bīhani kathā to the international flash fiction and sudden fiction traditions, though by a route internal to Maithili literary development rather than through explicit borrowing.

## 10. Critical Reception and Scholarship

Critical attention to the bīhani kathā remains, in the broader scholarly world, somewhat limited relative to the form's creative vitality. Most sustained critical discussion has occurred within the Videha orbit itself in the journal's pages, in Munnaji's writings, and in the work of critics like Bijayendra Jha whose 2025

IJCRT article represents one of the most comprehensive recent surveys of twentyfirstcentury Maithili short fiction. The Videha editorial introductions to the Sadeha anthologies constitute an important critical record, as does the blog and aggregator infrastructure maintained by the Videha network.

Academic scholarship in English on the bīhani kathā as a specific form is sparse. Mithilesh Kumar Jha's 2021 India Seminar article on 'Maithili in the Digital Space' discusses Videha's role in fostering new writers but does not focus specifically on the bīhani kathā form. There is scope for substantial further scholarly work in English and in Maithili itself on the formal, social, and cultural dimensions of the form.

The form's very brevity the same quality that makes it so suited to digital circulation has perhaps contributed to its relative critical neglect: very short texts tend to receive less critical attention than novels or even standard short stories, in Indian literary studies as in the international academy. The recognition accorded to the bīhani kathā by Videha's dedicated anthology and by the critical vocabulary developed by Munnaji and others constitutes a counterinstitutional move against this tendency.

## 11. Conclusion: The Seed and Its Future

The bīhani kathā is one of the most vital and theoretically interesting developments in contemporary Maithili literature. Born from the intersection of an ancient Maithili instinct for compressed, pointed narrative and the new conditions of digital publication, it has found in Videha an institutional home that has nurtured both creative practice and critical reflection on the form.

Several threads merit future research. First, a systematic comparison of the bīhani kathā with the haikulike compression of the Tamil kuruntokai and kuṟuntokai traditions, or with the Bengali chhotagalpa tradition, could shed light on the panIndian ecology of micronarrative. Second, the gender politics of the bīhani kathā its disproportionate attractiveness to women writers and its capacity for feminist social critique warrants dedicated feminist literarycritical attention. Third, the relationship between bīhani kathā and the Tirhuta script revival promoted by Videha raises interesting questions: does the form take on different resonances when written and read in Mithilakshar script rather than Devanagari?

Above all, the bīhani kathā stands as evidence that a minority language tradition officially recognized in the Indian Constitution since 2003, spoken by approximately 17 million people can generate not only a literature of richness

and variety but a formally innovative mode of writing that challenges, from within its own resources, the hegemony of longer, more 'prestigious' narrative forms. The seed story, as its name declares, carries within its brevity the potential of something much larger: a whole Maithili literary world.

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LESSON 005 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY

# Dalit Literary Criticism: Telugu, Gujarati, and Odia Dalit Literature in Maithili Translation

A Critical Review

Part I: Telugu Dalit Poetry

Critical Review of Dalit Poetry: Two Poems by Boyi Bhimanna

Burning Skulls and My Ancestral Rights

Prefatory Note

Boyi Bhimanna (1920–2001) was a foundational pillar of Telugu Dalit literature. His poetry is not merely an expression of personal suffering; it is a document of collective historical consciousness. The two poems presented here -Gudiselu Kalipothunnaayi and Naa Varasatvpu Hakkulu -represent two distinct yet mutually related dimensions of his poetic universe: on one side, the labyrinthine nature of religious violence; on the other, a counter-reading of mythological history.

1. Poetic Form and Structure

Burning Skulls

The most noteworthy formal characteristic of this poem is its question-and-answer structure. The poem continuously poses questions to itself -"Whose skull is this?", "From where does it rise again and again?" -and then answers itself, but that answer in turn transforms into a new question. This structure evokes the Socratic method, wherein a chain of questions reveals truth -except that here, truth is located not in a philosophical conclusion, but in a bitter social reality.

Repetition -"it burns", "it rises" -creates a mantra-like effect. The use of anaphora (beginning lines with the same word) and epistrophe (repeating the same word at the end of a line) brings this poem close to the oral tradition, to the

folk song -from which we may infer that Bhimanna is embedding Dalit oral-cultural tradition within written poetry.

My Ancestral Rights

In this poem the structure is more fragmented and narrative. The poem leaps from one mythological episode to another -Vasishtha, Arundhati, Matsyagandhi, Vyasa -as if a restless reader of history were turning pages. This fragmentation is not incidental; it is the symbol of Dalit historical consciousness, where memory is not whole but stolen and scattered.

The poem's final lines move like long, heavy breaths -"Only to cast away with pride! / Only to breathe with total dignity!" -this conclusion is a declaration of victory, but it contains not the exultation of triumph, but the experience of a grave, deep liberation.

2. Language and Metaphor

The Metaphor of the Skull

The central image of Burning Skulls -the skull that burns and is repeatedly reborn -is extraordinarily multi-layered. At one level it clearly signals caste violence: the history of collective violence upon Dalits, skulls being severed, being burned. At another level it is a sardonic use of the Hindu doctrine of rebirth -the poet asks: if the theory of reincarnation is true, why is this same Dalit burned again and again? Reincarnation was supposed to be the path to moksha -but for the Dalit it becomes an endless vicious circle.

This resonates with Frantz Fanon's analysis in The Wretched of the Earth (a philosophical treatise on the revolution against colonial exploitation), where he shows how colonial and caste systems entrap the victim in a cycle of violence in such a way that the victim begins to consider that cycle normal -until "the secret of these skulls becomes known to those who inhabit them."

The Metaphor of Digging a Graveyard

In My Ancestral Rights the image of digging a graveyard is extraordinarily complex. Ordinarily, digging a graveyard is associated with death, with ill omen. But here the poet inverts its meaning -digging a graveyard is an act of

retrieval. What had been buried -the Dalit's Vedic identity, their historical rights -to dig it out and bring it forth becomes a revolutionary act.

Here one hears an echo of Walter Benjamin's "Theses on the Philosophy of History" (a philosophical essay that demands history be seen from the perspective of the victim, not the conqueror). Benjamin says that history is always written from the victor's viewpoint, and the revolutionary task is to revive "dangerous memory" -gefährliche Erinnerung. Bhimanna does exactly this: he excavates that "dangerous memory" which Brahmanical historiography had buried and kept buried.

3. The Counter-Mythological Reading

My Ancestral Rights stands within an important tradition of Dalit literature -the inverted reading of mythological narrative. This tradition was established by B.R. Ambedkar in Riddles in Hinduism and Who Were the Shudras? Bhimanna interrogates the entire Mahabharata-Ramayana-Vedic tradition by this method.

The poem's central argument is this: the great personalities of the Vedic-Aryan tradition were in fact of casteless or Dalit origin -Vasishtha, Matsyagandhi, Vyasa. But Brahmanical history "Aryanized" them, and kept their true descendants -the Dalits -excluded. This is an unveiling of a historical irony.

Here the perspective of Subaltern Studies (the scholarly tradition of bringing the history and voices of marginalized peoples to the center) is pertinent. Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak asks in Can the Subaltern Speak? whether the Dalit woman can be present in history in her own voice. Bhimanna's poem is an answer to this question: he makes the subaltern speak -giving Matsyagandhi, Amba, Ambalika -who in the Mahabharata were merely objects -a capacity for self-determination: "If she had slapped and knocked his teeth out..." -this counter-historical imagination (reimagining history through speculation about what would have happened if it were reversed) is the re-creation of the subaltern's agency.

4. The Dalit-Woman Dimension

In both these poems -especially in My Ancestral Rights -a Dalit-feminist intersectional perspective (analyzing the simultaneous oppression of caste and gender) is clearly visible. Arundhati, Matsyagandhi, Amba, Ambalika -these are all women upon whom caste-based and gender-based exploitation occurred simultaneously. The poem presents them not merely as victims, but as potential rebels.

Kimberlé Crenshaw's theory of intersectionality (in which she shows that caste, gender, and class oppressions do not occur separately but simultaneously) applies directly here. Bhimanna -a Dalit male poet -writes poetry from this multi-oppression perspective, which is evidence of the breadth of his poetic vision.

5. Dalit Aesthetics

Critics of Dalit literature -Sharankumar Limbale (Towards an Aesthetic of Dalit Literature), Omprakash Valmiki -have repeatedly emphasized that Dalit literature cannot be measured by the standards of Western poetics. In Dalit poetry:

Anger is an aesthetic category, not a flaw. Political directness is not artistic weakness but ethical necessity. Personal and collective experience are one -the "I" is always the representative of a social "we."

Both of Bhimanna's poems are outstanding examples of this aesthetics. The anger of Burning Skulls is not rhetoric (hollow emotion deployed merely for oratorical effect) -it is an authentic ethical emotion. The scholarship of My Ancestral Rights -mythological references, historical consciousness -is not a mere display of erudition, but a cultural project of self-respect.

6. The Challenge of Translation

The Maithili translation of these poems (itself made from an English translation) is a double translation -Telugu → English → Maithili. Some poetic loss is inevitable in this.

For instance: the word gudiselu (skull/hut) carries a double meaning in Telugu -a hut that is burned. The word khopadi (skull) in Maithili was able to preserve that ambiguity quite well.

But the emotional intensity of "Naa Varasatvpu Hakkulu" -where equal stress falls on both "naa" (mine) and "hakkulu" (rights) -is somewhat dissolved in the Maithili "hamar paitrik adhikaar" (my ancestral rights).

Even within the constraints of this double translation, the fundamental poetic power of both poems has come through in Maithili -because the force of Bhimanna's thought cannot be made subaltern by any linguistic medium.

Conclusion

These two poems of Boyi Bhimanna stand at the highest level of Dalit literature -where poetic craft and political philosophy become one. Burning Skulls presents the cyclical nature of religious violence in the form of a mystical question, while My Ancestral Rights declares, through a counter-reading of history, the restoration of Dalit identity.

Both poems together present a complete Dalit philosophy: to question, to remember, to reclaim, and finally to breathe free with pride. This is not merely poetry -it is a document of a civilizational struggle.

Part II: Dalit Women's Poetry -J. Subhadra's Four Poems

Grinding, Laanda, The Sari's Edge, Avva

Prefatory Note

J. Subhadra is a distinctive voice in Telugu Dalit women's poetry. While Bhimanna's poetry performs a counter-reading of Dalit identity from the historical-mythological dimension, Subhadra's poetry establishes the body, labor, and domestic objects -leather, the clay pot, the sari's edge -at the center of poetry. Her four poems together present a panorama of a complete Dalit woman's life: from field to home, from labor to motherhood, from hunger to dignity.

1. Poetic Form and Structure

Grinding

This poem's structure takes the form of a catalogue of labor. From morning to night, each task comes one after another -sweeping, smearing, fetching water, clearing dung -without any pause or conjunction. This list-form is not incidental; it represents the breathless continuity of the Dalit woman's life. Walt Whitman's Song of Myself also uses a catalogue of labor -but there the catalogue is a symbol of liberation; here it is of bondage.

The final question -"How will this bonded life end?" -ties the entire weight of the poem into a single thread. Not a rhetorical question -this is a genuine, unanswered question.

Laanda

This poem's structure is a process narrative -the complete process of rotting leather, cleaning it, softening it. This technical precision is unusual in poetry. The sap of the Indian laburnum, the seeds of the tamarind -these are recordings of indigenous knowledge that Subhadra is inscribing within poetry. In this sense the poem is also an ethnographic document.

At the poem's end -"For creaking shoes and making drums -/ he beats a sweet rhythm on that drum" -there is a bitter irony. The leather that the woman prepares in degraded circumstances, from that same leather her husband beats a "sweet rhythm" on a drum. Subhadra exposes here the asymmetric relationship between labor and art, pain and beauty.

The Sari's Edge

This is the longest and most complex of the four poems. Its structure is based on an extended metaphor -the sari's edge is the same object that repeatedly takes new forms: bed, umbrella, bag, cushion, protector, mother. This metamorphic sequence reflects the many-faceted nature of the Dalit woman's life -who is simultaneously laborer, mother, wife, beggar, and tenacious warrior.

The final lines -"This cloth is not a guard standing watch over my chest" -negate the very title. This is a performative contradiction: what was said in the title, the poem rejects. From this a dialectical tension is created -in what sense is the sari's edge not a guard? The poet leaves this question open.

Avva

This poem's structure is the most lyrical and elegiac of all. The repetition of the word "Avva" -which means "mother" in Telugu -assumes the form of an invocation, as if a goddess were being summoned in a ritual. But this is a goddess of domestic labor, not enthroned on a golden seat.

The poem's sequence of images is extraordinarily dense: the sun that has been lost in the sky's carpet, the grain in the empty granary, the beat of a torn drum-skin. These are all figures of absence and displacement.

2. The Central Figure: Object-Poetics

Subhadra's poetry's most significant characteristic is -making ordinary objects the center of poetry: Laanda (the vessel for rotting leather), the clay pot, the sari's edge, the mattock, the sickle.

In Western poetics the poem about an object (Dinggedicht) is an established tradition -Rainer Maria Rilke's Neue Gedichte is its outstanding example. But Rilke's objects are objects of beauty -Apollo's torso, the panther. Subhadra's objects are objects of labor -which are foul-smelling, filthy, and socially humiliated.

From this emerges a new poetics of Dalit object poetics: through the object, making the Dalit woman's labor, knowledge, and identity visible. What society does not wish to see -leather rotting, searching for grain-husks in mud -the poet places at the center of literature.

3. Body-Politics and Material Reality

In Laanda one line is extraordinary: "Even if my intestines come out through my mouth, / Even if I fall unconscious -because of the worms and the stench, / this fate of tanning leather must be endured!"

This visceral realism -the mention of internal organs, olfactory response, physical fainting -is a distinctive tendency of Dalit literature that Gopal Guru calls "radical embodiment." In upper-caste literature, the body is generally idealized or abstract. In Dalit literature the body is concrete, suffering, and laboring -with no apology in this.

In The Sari's Edge the body's presence takes a different form -sweat, tears, menstrual blood -these are all bodily fluids that the Brahmanical purity-pollution system considers "impure." Subhadra accepts all these naturally in her poetry -this is a negation of the purity myth.

Julia Kristeva's theory of abjection is pertinent here. According to Kristeva, society considers "abject" -disgusting, excluded -those elements that break the body's boundaries: blood, excrement, decay. Subhadra, by making these abjected elements the subject of her poetry, refuses social abjection itself.

4. Intersectionality: Caste, Gender, and Class

In all four poems, caste, gender, and class -all three are simultaneously present, and their mutual interaction never separates.

In Grinding: the compulsion to work in the landlord's house (class+caste) + "beaten with a stick" (caste violence) + the entire burden of this on the woman (gender).

In Avva: "she chars in the furnace of her father's rage" -domestic violence (gender) + "the landlords kept him away from the plough" (caste+class) -both in the same woman's life at once.

Kimberlé Crenshaw's theory of intersectionality comes to life literally here. The Dalit woman is neither merely a representative of Dalits nor merely of women -she is a third category whose experience is different from and more complex than either.

Sharmila Rege has presented the concept of a "Dalit feminist standpoint" in this context -the Dalit woman's perspective is an epistemological privilege, because she inhabits the deepest level of oppression. Subhadra's poetry is written from this standpoint.

5. Motherhood and Want: A Special Reading of Avva

Avva is an extraordinary counter-reading of motherhood-poetry. In Hindi-Sanskrit literature, the mother is generally a symbol of sacrifice, gentleness, and nurturance -Yashoda, Kaushalya. Subhadra's Avva is fundamentally different from these.

She is a mother who cannot sing a lullaby, because she is at work. She is a mother whose hands are rough and dirty, because she is always in the fields. She is a mother who cannot put her child to sleep in her lap, because she is the landlord's bonded laborer.

Here there is an echo of Adrienne Rich's Of Woman Born, where she analyzes motherhood at two levels -as institution (social obligation) and as experience. For Subhadra's Avva, both are simultaneously present -but the former is always subordinate to the latter. Survival comes before tenderness -this is the tragedy of the Dalit mother.

6. Folk Aesthetics and Indigenous Knowledge

In Laanda the specific use of Indian laburnum and tamarind, in The Sari's Edge the reference to "Maisamma Devi," in Avva the songs of transplanting, harvesting, and threshing -these are all the poetic archiving of Dalit folk tradition.

Ganesh Devy argues in After Amnesia that Indian literary criticism always kept the Sanskrit/Urdu/English canon at the center and considered the Dalit-tribal oral tradition "extra-literary." Subhadra's poetry refuses this canonical exclusion -she installs Dalit folk knowledge, oral tradition, regional botanical knowledge on the high ground of poetry.

7. The Sari's Edge and the Jayaprabha Episode

At the end of the poem there is an important footnote -a reference to Jayaprabha's Telugu feminist poem "Set Ablaze the Sari-End." Jayaprabha's poem considers the sari's edge a symbol of patriarchy and calls for its burning.

Subhadra clearly disagrees with this upper-caste feminist perspective. For her Avva, the sari's edge is neither a symbol of patriarchy nor an enemy of liberation. It is an instrument of livelihood -bed, protection, bag, mother. To burn it means burning the one thing she has.

This intra-feminist dialogue is of great importance. Audre Lorde says in Sister Outsider: "The master's tools will never dismantle the master's house" -but the question here is: which feminism, whose feminism? From the Dalit woman's perspective, upper-caste feminist symbolism sometimes becomes class-blind and caste-blind. Subhadra challenges this blindness -without aggression, but with firmness.

8. Language and the Context of Maithili Translation

These poems have made a journey of three levels -Telugu → English → Maithili. In this journey some important references have been preserved:

"Laanda" -the Telugu word was kept as-is, which was a sound decision. Its Maithili translation would have been difficult, and the power of the original technical-cultural word would have been lost.

"Avva" -"mai" (mother) was not used, "Avva" was used. This preserved the Telugu cultural specificity.

But "Kongu naa boche mida kaavalunde bonthapegwadu" (The Sari's Edge) -the visceral immediacy of the Telugu title has somewhat diminished in Maithili. In Telugu, both "boche" (chest/breast) and "kaavalunde" (keeping guard) -the bodily-political tension of both words has become somewhat more literal in the Maithili "chhaati par pahara da rahl kapada" (cloth keeping watch over the chest).

Conclusion

J. Subhadra's four poems together create an epic of Dalit women's life -fragmented, but complete. From labor to motherhood, from body to history, from a sari's edge to an entire civilizational struggle.

Her poetic achievement is this: she never complains -she bears witness. Simone Weil considered the distinction between justice and compassion important: complaint comes from the victim, testimony from the witness. Subhadra becomes the witness to her own life -and from this her poetry becomes not merely a personal cry of anguish but a historical document.

The final line -"she never reached as far as where my Avva had walked" -is the epitaph of the entire collection: language, history, and civilization -all together have failed to map the complete geography of the Dalit woman's life.

## Part III: Dalit Women's Poetry -Comparative and Synthetic Study

### 9. Both Poets Together: Poetic Dialogue Between Bhimanna and Subhadra

Reading both sections of this review together -Bhimanna's poems and Subhadra's four -a dialectical dialogue emerges that reveals the complexities within Dalit literature.

#### Difference of Perspective

Bhimanna looks from above -history, mythology, philosophy, the long arc of civilization. His poetic camera is wide-angle. Subhadra looks from within -body, object, labor, home, mother. Her poetic camera is close-up.

Bhimanna's My Ancestral Rights excavates the history of Vyasa and Vasishtha -a macro-history. Subhadra's Avva depicts the labor of a single day of an unnamed mother -a micro-history. But both are two sides of the same truth: historical theft and daily exploitation -two faces of one coin.

In this sense both poets' collections together build a bridge between Carlo Ginzburg's microhistory and Marxist macrohistory -where the trivial details of individual life connect with the epic of social structure.

The Difference Between Questioning and Bearing Witness

Bhimanna questions -"How do these skulls rise again and again?", "How long will this vicious cycle continue?" His poetry is in the interrogative mode.

Subhadra bears witness -"when my husband with his own hands rubs lime and applies it to the leather", "I cannot remember ever having clung tightly to Avva's waist and hung from her." Her poetry is in the testimonial mode.

In Western literary theory, testimony is a special genre whose development occurred in Holocaust literature -Elie Wiesel, Primo Levi. But Shoshana Felman and Dori Laub show in Testimony: Crises of Witnessing that testimony is not merely a factual report -it is an ethical act in which the victim transforms their experience into evidence. Each of Subhadra's poems is testimony in this sense.

10. Nature-Images in Dalit Poetry: A Counter-Reading

In upper-caste Hindi-Sanskrit poetry, nature is generally the realm of aesthetic experience -in Kalidasa's Meghadutam the background to the yaksha's longing, in Chhayavaad the projection of the soul. In this tradition nature is romantic.

Subhadra's nature-images are fundamentally different:

In Avva -"the sun rising before the cock crows scorches Avva's eyes" -the sun's rising here is not poetic beauty, but a signal of labor's beginning. The sun does not wake the mother -it burns her.

In The Sari's Edge -"in the rains the sari's edge becomes an umbrella of Indian laburnum flowers" -the Indian laburnum would be the subject of beauty for an upper-caste poet; here it is practical shelter.

In Grinding -dust, cracks in the stone, mud -this is the landscape in which the Dalit woman works, which the Chhayavaad poets never saw.

In this sense Subhadra demolishes pastoral ideology -which considers rural nature a place of peace. Raymond Williams showed in The Country and the City that pastoral is a class conspiracy that renders labor invisible. Subhadra's poetry makes that invisible labor visible.

11. Silence and Absence in Poetry

What is left unsaid in both poets' works is no less important than what is said.

In Bhimanna's Burning Skulls the murderer is never named -"religion" is an abstract force. In this strategic anonymity there is a literary diplomacy: when the murderer is a system, not an individual, naming it is unnecessary -because naming does not change the system.

In Subhadra's Avva the mother's voice is absent. She sings -but we do not hear her song; she speaks -but we do not know her words. This silence is a symbol of the historical absence of the Dalit woman -she who never became a subject in history, always remained an object.

Jacques Derrida says in his concept of trace that meaning is found not only in presence but also in the mark of absence. Subhadra's poem's silence -Avva's unheard lullaby, her unspoken words -is this trace, where the Dalit woman's history is inscribed.

12. Anger, Grief, and Dignity: Three Emotional Registers

In these nine poems -Bhimanna's five and Subhadra's four -there are three primary emotional registers:

Anger -in Bhimanna's Burning Skulls and My Ancestral Rights. This anger is philosophical anger -not personal, but cultural.

Grief -in Subhadra's Avva and Grinding. This grief is collective mourning -for the lost lives of an entire generation.

Dignity -in the final lines of The Sari's Edge, in the final proclamation of My Ancestral Rights. This dignity is earned -based not on charity but on rights.

Aristotle speaks in poetry of catharsis -emotional purification. But in Dalit poetry catharsis is of a different nature. It is not for the emotional purification of the audience -it is a call for the moral purification of society. Ambedkar used to say: "I measure the progress of a community by the degree of progress which women have achieved." By this measure these poems measure society -and find society wanting.

13. The Maithili Literary Tradition and the Relevance of Dalit Poetry

The translation of these Telugu Dalit poems into Maithili -through the medium of Videha magazine -is a literary-cultural project whose importance goes beyond the technical achievement of translation.

The Dalit voice in Maithili literature has historically remained marginal. The Sahitya Akademi-recognized Maithili canon has generally remained Brahmin-Kayastha-centered -from Vidyapati through the modern era. It was only after

the intervention of the parallel literature movement, the real vidyapati has come to fore (Annexure-2, A Critical Appraisal of *Vidyapati's Bidesiya; Annexure-3 [Vidyapati, the Primal Poet of Maithili (Pre-Jyotirishvara);* ANNEXURE: 4 A Critical Theory for Maithili Original and Translated Dalit Prose-Poetry Literature**]** In this context the Maithili translation of Telugu Dalit-woman poetry is a canonical intervention.

This translation says to Maithili readers: the reality of the Dalit woman is not merely a subject for Telugu -it is equally present in the soil of Mithila. Geographic specificity (Telugu context) and social universality (Dalit-woman oppression) -accepting both simultaneously is the most important literary-political decision of this translation project.

The vision that the Parallel Literature Movement represents through Videha -beyond-canon, folk-tradition-enriched, Dalit-woman-voice-inclusive -these poems are the living proof of that vision.

14. Final Synthesis: A New Poetics

Bhimanna and Subhadra's poems together establish certain foundational principles of Dalit poetics that are fundamentally different from Western and upper-caste Indian poetics:

First -Democracy of Poetic Subject: tanning leather, searching for grain in mud, an old sari's edge -these are as worthy of poetry as the yaksha's longing in Meghadutam or Shraddha in Kamayani.

Second -The Moral Validity of Emotion: anger, hatred, grief -these are considered incomplete in Rasa theory (Shanta Rasa being supreme). In Dalit poetry anger is morally necessary.

Third -The Indivisibility of Politics and Aesthetics: "art for art's sake" is meaningless in Dalit poetry. The poem is a social act -testimony, accusation, and call to liberation simultaneously.

Fourth -Respect for Local Knowledge: Indian laburnum, tamarind, Maisamma Devi, Laanda -these are all Dalit epistemology that precedes and is sometimes superior to book-knowledge.

Fifth -The Body as Political Terrain: the Dalit woman's body -which burns, tires, rots, sheds tears -upon this body all three systems of caste, class, and

gender work simultaneously. Making this body visible in poetry is a political act.

Closing

Audre Lorde writes in The Transformation of Silence into Language and Action that silence will not protect you -"your silence will not protect you." Boyi Bhimanna and J. Subhadra -both -break this silence. Bhimanna breaks the silence of history, Subhadra the silence of daily life.

From one language to another -from Telugu to Maithili -these voices make a journey. Translation here is not merely linguistic transfer -it is an act of solidarity: one Dalit community hears another Dalit community's voice, recognizes it, and keeps it alive in its own language.

In this sense these poems -Bhimanna's and Subhadra's -are not merely a translation in Maithili literature, but the planting of a new poetic tradition's seed.

Part IV: Challpalli Swarooparani's Two Poems

Mankenapuvvu and Hands Turned to Earth

Prefatory Note

Challpalli Swarooparani is a distinctive voice in Telugu Dalit-women's poetry that gives a new dimension to the poetic tradition of Bhimanna and Subhadra. While Bhimanna works on the historical-mythological level and Subhadra on the level of object-labor-motherhood, Swarooparani's poetry occupies a third position -she places the transformation of personal consciousness at the center. Her poetry begins with "I" and ends with "I" -but this "I" is different at both ends of the journey.

1. Poetic Form and Structure

Mankenapuvvu

This poem's structure is a three-tiered narrative. In the first tier, a central metaphor is established at the poem's beginning -a blue bird caught in a thorny

bush. In the second and longest tier there is a series of anaphoric beginnings -"when... then" -repeated six times. In the third tier, the poem suddenly turns -"But when my patience runs out" -and transforms into an explosive proclamation.

This three-tiered structure is a dialectical counterpart of thesis-antithesis-synthesis. But it differs from Hegelian dialectics in that synthesis here is not compromise -it is rebellion.

In the six repetitions of "when... then" it is worth noting that each "then" expresses a desire for self-negation -to sink like a seed, to close one's nose, to contract into a fist, to pour in lead, to bury one's head. These are five specific images of self-negation that together create an accumulated pain. But the very intensity of this accumulated pain makes the final explosion credible.

Hands Turned to Earth

This poem's structure is chronological -from morning to evening, from youth to decay. But this chronology is not simply linear -it is spiral (winding up and down). The same day repeats again and again, the same year again and again, the same life again and again. From this recurrent spiraling emerges a deep nihilism -no change, no end.

Comparing with Subhadra's Avva: both are poems about a mother, both describe labor -but in Avva there is a daughter's gaze, while in Hands Turned to Earth there is a third-person witness's gaze. This difference is significant: Swarooparani here regards the mother not with love but with judicial eyes.

2. Central Figures: Bird, Flower, and Earth

The Blue Bird and the Silk-Cotton Flower

Mankenapuvvu's two central images -the blue bird caught in a thorny bush and the red silk-cotton flower blooming at the end -present a chromatic journey (emotional journey through color). Blue (the bird's color) -sadness, bondage, unfulfilled longing for sky. Red (the silk-cotton flower's color) -rebellion, blood, life-force.

The silk-cotton flower (Bombax ceiba) carries a specific meaning in Telugu-Andhra culture -it blooms on a thorny tree, alone, blazing red in winter when there are no leaves. It is the cultural symbol of blooming in adversity.

Swarooparani transforms this indigenous symbolism into a metaphor of Dalit-women's consciousness.

In Western poetry the metaphor of the phoenix (the mythological bird that rises reborn from ash) is consonant with this -but the phoenix is consumed in ash and then rises. Swarooparani's protagonist is not consumed -she blooms right there among the thorns. This is an important difference: the Dalit woman's liberation does not come through destruction -it comes through transformation.

Hands Turned to Earth

The title-metaphor of Hands Turned to Earth is multi-dimensional. "Hands turned to earth" -hands sunk into earth by labor -is a literal description. But in it both becoming earth (the devaluation of humanity) and being made of earth (fundamental elemental identity) are inherent.

In Grinding, Subhadra searches for grain-husks in mud. In Hands Turned to Earth, Swarooparani watches woman herself dissolving into mud. This progressive intensification is important -when labor becomes so intense that laborer and earth become one, this is the extreme state of objectification (treating humans as objects).

Marx in the Economic and Philosophic Manuscripts describes alienated labor (in which the worker is cut off from their work, their humanity, and nature). Swarooparani's "hands turned to earth" is the physical symbol of this alienation.

3. Analysis of the "When... Then" Series

Mankenapuvvu's six-repetition "when... then" series presents a taxonomy of oppression (list of different levels of oppression). Each "when" has a different level of oppression:

First -Control of domestic aesthetics: not applying kajal or a bindi. This is the most intimate level -control over one's own body.

Second -Spatial control: "the foul-smelling village" -the physical encirclement of the Dalit settlement.

Third -Educational exclusion: caste-based rejection at the threshold of higher education.

Fourth -Stigmatization based on reservations: "coming from quota" -making reservations a weapon of humiliation.

Fifth -Sexual objectification (treating woman merely as object of desire): not marriageable, merely an object of lust.

These five levels together demonstrate the encirclement from all directions of the Dalit woman's life -home, village, education, work, marriage -surrounded from every side. The realism of this encirclement resonates with Patricia Hill Collins's theory of the matrix of domination (in which she shows that oppression is not a single force but a cluster of mutually interwoven systems).

Particularly important is the mention of stigmatization through reservations -which is absent in Bhimanna or Subhadra's poetry. Swarooparani here encompasses contemporary Dalit experience: even having gained access to education and government employment, the Dalit woman continues to be stigmatized as a "quota beneficiary." This is a new form of twenty-first century oppression that maintains the old social hierarchy in a new language.

4. Body-Politics: Two Different Paths

Both poems contain the presence of the body -but on two different paths.

In Mankenapuvvu, the body is the site of capacity and rebellion. "I will bloom", "I will flow" -this body, caught in thorns until the end, ultimately gains self-determination (the right to decide for oneself).

In Hands Turned to Earth, the body is the site of decay and consumption. "She who shone like a marigold, / fades like a dried leaf on a stem" -this body is destroyed by the double consumption of labor and patriarchy.

In these two paths a generational gap can be seen. The "I" of Mankenapuvvu is possibly educated, aware, rebellious -the Dalit woman of the new generation. The "she" of Hands Turned to Earth is possibly uneducated, unaware, exhausted -the Dalit woman of the old generation. Both are products of the same system -but different at the level of consciousness.

Frantz Fanon in The Wretched of the Earth shows two levels of colonized consciousness: those who have accepted the system from within, and those who

have begun to reject it. Swarooparani presents both these consciousnesses together -in two poems -in one collection.

5. The Husband-Figure: A Comparison in Two Poems

The husband is present in both poems -but in different forms.

In Mankenapuvvu -"male control at home slaps her on one cheek" -the husband is a nameless force, an equal partner in the caste system. No name, no face -merely force.

In Hands Turned to Earth -"the husband is ready to drink up her sweat like liquor" and "bearing the husband's hand-and-foot beatings in the evening" -the husband is a concrete oppressor, present in daily life.

This contrast is significant from a literary-political perspective. In the first poem, patriarchy is structural (in the form of a system); in the second it is interpersonal (between two individuals). Both are true -but both together construct the complete picture of patriarchy: it is simultaneously system and individual.

bell hooks argues in Feminist Theory: From Margin to Center that the feminist movement sometimes sees patriarchy only structurally and gives less importance to individual male violence -or the reverse. Swarooparani's two poems together reject this false dichotomy.

6. The Final Image: Two Contrasting Endings

Mankenapuvvu ends on a triumphant conclusion:

"I will bloom like Mankenapuvvu! / I will flow like a river, / crossing the forest of torment."

This conclusion gives the reader emotional catharsis -the experience of victory after suffering. But this catharsis is not cheap -it comes after the entire poem's accumulated suffering, and for that reason its weight is extraordinary.

Hands Turned to Earth ends on a tragic conclusion:

"On the stony desert road of life -/ carrying the cross of hunger."

The use of the word "cross" here is of utmost importance. This is borrowed Christian symbolism -Jesus's carrying of the cross. But here it is used in a secular sense: the Dalit woman carries the cross without any assurance of

liberation, without any resurrection. This is a crucifixion without resurrection -a more brutal image than Christian symbolism.

Albert Camus in The Myth of Sisyphus describes the philosophy of absurdism -Sisyphus pushes the rock up again and again, and it falls down again and again. Camus says: "We must imagine Sisyphus happy." But for Swarooparani's protagonist this existentialist solution is unavailable -because Camus's Sisyphus is an abstract philosophical figure, while Swarooparani's protagonist is historical, material, embodied.

7. Comparison with Subhadra: Similarity and Difference

Both poets make Dalit women's life the subject of poetry -but there are several important differences in their poetic vision:

Pace: Subhadra's poetry is slow, meditative -looking at each object, each moment with complete attention. Swarooparani's poetry is rapid, passionate -as if a dam were breaking.

Perspective: Subhadra is an inner witness -she is herself within that life. Swarooparani in Mankenapuvvu is an inner witness, while in Hands Turned to Earth she is a compassionate outer witness -she sees another woman's life.

Resolution: Subhadra's The Sari's Edge was resolution-less, open-ended. Swarooparani's Mankenapuvvu offers a clear resolution -rebellion and blooming. In this sense Swarooparani is more manifesto-like -her poetry contains the element of a political manifesto.

8. Linguistic Features

In Mankenapuvvu there is a notable linguistic characteristic -a relative absence of sensory specificity. The poem works on the emotional and ideational level, less on the concrete sensory detail. This differs from Subhadra's poetry where Indian laburnum sap, tamarind seeds, the clay pot's cushion -all are concrete and sensory.

But in Hands Turned to Earth sensory richness is present -"mud up to the knees", "terrible dancing of the gut in the stomach", "the music of brahmin vessels." From this one understands that both types of language are available in Swarooparani's poetic repertoire -she chooses according to context.

"The music of brahmin vessels" -calling the sound of scrubbing vessels "music" -is a bitter irony. Upper-class aesthetics that finds music in violin-sitar; for the Dalit woman the first "music" of morning is the clanking of bronze vessels. This inversion of aesthetic values is evidence of Swarooparani's poetic intelligence.

## 9. The Three Poets: A Comprehensive Vision

Coming now to the third section of this review -seeing Bhimanna, Subhadra, and Swarooparani together -a triangular structure of Telugu Dalit poetry emerges:

Bhimanna -the poet of history and philosophy: at the broadest level he questions the historical and mythological foundations of the caste system.

Subhadra -the poet of labor and objects: at the microscopic level she makes visible the concrete reality of daily life -each object, each act of labor.

Swarooparani -the poet of consciousness and transformation: at the intermediary level -between the historical and the daily -she captures personal consciousness, the inner experience of oppression, and the transformation of that consciousness.

All three together cover the full Dalit-woman experience -from outside to inside, from history to present, from suffering to rebellion.

Conclusion

Challpalli Swarooparani's two poems -Mankenapuvvu and Hands Turned to Earth -are the finest expression of the dialectic of hope and despair in Dalit women's poetry. Mankenapuvvu says: I will bloom -despite the thorns. Hands Turned to Earth says: without structural change, this blooming is not possible.

Both poems together create a complete political message: individual rebellion is possible and necessary -but until structural change occurs, the protagonist of Hands Turned to Earth will be born again and again and will die again and again carrying her cross.

This double truth -the possibility of individual liberation and the necessity of collective liberation -is Swarooparani's most important poetic achievement.

Part V: Darishee Shashinirrrmala's Three Poems

It is I Who Lost Everything, I am Wearing Menstrual Cloth, A Dalit Woman

Prefatory Note

Darishee Shashinirmala is a most aggressive and confrontational voice in Telugu Dalit women's poetry. Moving beyond Bhimanna's historical-philosophical analysis, Subhadra's labor-object-poetry, and Swarooparani's transformation of personal consciousness, Shashinirmala occupies an entirely different poetic terrain. She fights in three directions at once: against upper-caste men, against Dalit men, and against upper-caste women. In this three-fronted struggle her poetry occupies a political terrain that is extraordinary in the Telugu Dalit poetic tradition.

1. Poetic Form and Structure

It is I Who Lost Everything

This poem's structure takes the form of a dialogue -but an extraordinary dialogue in which the other side never responds. "You" -an upper-caste woman

-is the entire target of the poem. The poet speaks to her, but does not wait for her response -because that response is impossible.

This one-sided dialogue is a distinctive technique in poetics. In Shakespeare's plays the soliloquy (speaking alone) reveals inner conflict -this differs from it. Here it is not a soliloquy but an unheard dialogue. The poet speaks -the other side does not listen. In this structural deafness the reality of upper-caste women's feminism is revealed.

The final five lines come in the form of questions -"Will you step down one step?", "Will we walk on the same path?" -these are not rhetorical questions but genuine tests. The poet compels the upper-caste woman to make a concrete choice.

I am Wearing Menstrual Cloth

This poem's structure is the most complex and multi-layered. It is simultaneously a personal lament, a political manifesto, and a historical document. The structure works on three levels:

First level -personal body-experience: menstruation, sweat, humiliation at the well. Second level -social-political analysis: media, police, court, caste violence. Third level -historical evidence: Alisamma, Muthavva, Mahadevamma -the names of real victims.

These three levels become one in the poem -personal, social, and historical in the same breath. In this three-level unity lies the core of Shashinirmala's poetic power.

A Dalit Woman

This poem's structure is a progressively expanding list of accusations (a series of charges that grows larger and larger with each line). Each line adds a new humiliation, a new exploitation -until the list becomes so heavy that the reader is crushed. But at the end an abrupt reversal occurs -"Now I am opening my mouth and eyes" -which transforms the entire weight of the poem into rebellion.

## 2. The Politics of the Title

In all three poems the title is itself a political statement.

"It is I Who Lost Everything" -here there is a sardonic self-accusation (blaming oneself, but in irony). The poet says: yes, I lost -but who is responsible for this loss? The title does not answer -it asks the reader.

"I am Wearing Menstrual Cloth" -the word "menstrual" is considered extremely stigmatized in the Hindu-Brahmanical purity-pollution system. To make it a title is a deliberate provocation (making the reader uncomfortable). To drape this cloth -that is, to cover oneself with it -over the "false logic" and "cleverness" of the society that hates this word -is a poetic retaliation.

"A Dalit Woman" -this is the simplest and therefore most powerful title. "A" -indefinite singular -says this is not the story of one individual, it is the story of all Dalit women. This title is simultaneously personal and universal.

## 3. The Critique of Upper-Caste Women's Feminism: It is I Who Lost Everything

This poem displays a rare poetic courage in Telugu -indeed, in all Indian -Dalit literature: it directly addresses the upper-caste woman and questions her feminist claim.

The poem's central episode is this: the upper-caste woman (possibly the poet's employer or neighbor) says to her husband "You fool!" -meaning she appears to speak in favor of the Dalit woman. But that same feminist upper-caste woman

does not stop her daughter's aggression, considers the Dalit woman "subordinate," and ultimately only "advocates" for her when the Dalit woman herself "makes a fist."

This is an exposure of feminism's double standard (the feminism of the upper-caste woman that speaks in favor of the Dalit woman but in practice maintains the caste hierarchy). Audre Lorde says in Sister Outsider (in which she criticizes white feminism's caste-blindness) that the claim of women's solidarity becomes hollow when class and caste difference is not acknowledged. Shashinirmala's poem brings this theory into the concrete Indian-caste reality.

Uma Chakravarti argues in Gendering Caste (in which she shows that caste and gender are two wings of the same system) that in India the upper-caste woman is simultaneously a victim of patriarchy (on the basis of gender) and a beneficiary of the caste system (on the basis of caste). Shashinirmala's poem presents this contradiction -without any theoretical overlay, in naked reality.

"As long as it's only man or only woman, then there's no problem" -this line is the philosophical essence of the entire poem. When identity remains only single-dimensional (merely gender or merely caste), compromise is possible. When the Dalit woman firmly assumes her multi-dimensional identity (caste+gender+class) -then the conflict over boundary-lines begins.

4. Body, Purity, and Resistance: I am Wearing Menstrual Cloth

The central metaphor of this poem -the menstrual cloth -performs multi-layered poetic work.

Negating the Purity Myth

In the Hindu varnashrama system the menstruating woman is considered impure. "Wearing" this cloth -that is, covering oneself with it -is an inversion: to drape over the "lies" of the society that considers the woman impure through this cloth, this "impure" cloth -is to make impurity into a weapon.

Julia Kristeva's abjection theory (in which she shows that society considers abject -disgusting, excluded -those things that break the body's boundaries -blood, discharge, excrement -and through this disgust maintains social hierarchy) is relevant here again. Shashinirmala transforms this abjected element into a political weapon.

Historical Evidence

At the poem's end, the mention of Alisamma, Muthavva, and Mahadevamma -who were stripped naked and paraded by upper-caste men -is a historical anchor (grounding the poem in reality through the concrete events of history). From this the poem does not remain merely a personal lyrical outpouring -it becomes a vessel of collective memory.

Walter Benjamin's concept of "dangerous memory" is worthy of recollection here again -but here this memory is even more dangerous, because it is not abstract historical fact but the names of real women.

Institutional Failure

"Neither the police's stick, / nor the court's gaze -/ they have nothing to do with my flayed skin" -these lines clearly expose the caste-partisanship of the state apparatus. Police and court -considered symbols of impartial justice -are here indifferent or hostile institutions for the Dalit woman.

Michel Foucault's power-knowledge relation (in which he shows that the justice system, the medical system, and other such institutions are not actually neutral but instruments of power-relations) comes to life here. Shashinirmala presents this philosophical insight in the language of poetry -without any theoretical terminology.

## 5. The Three-Fronted Oppression: A Dalit Woman

A Dalit Woman is one of the most politically complex poems in Telugu Dalit poetry, because it simultaneously fights against three oppressors.

The poem's first section (from the beginning to "draining my body's strength drop by drop") -description of upper-caste men's oppression.

The poem's second section (from "Why? / My own Dalit people...") -mention of Dalit men's oppression -"making me a rope for hanging their clothes on", "to use as post and nail for their skulls."

The poem's third section (from "Why? / My own women-folk...") -upper-caste women's oppression -"making me the decorative border of their high-caste sari."

This acknowledgment of three-fronted oppression is an extraordinarily courageous act in Dalit women's poetry. Acknowledging the oppression of Dalit men -this has been a taboo subject in the politics of Dalit solidarity. Shashinirmala breaks this taboo.

Babasaheb Ambedkar used to say that the condition of the Dalit woman was the most pitiable among the Dalits -she is excluded from three sides based on caste from society, based on gender from the Dalit community, and based on class from the upper-caste woman. Shashinirmala's poem gives poetic evidence of Ambedkar's insight.

Sharmila Rege's concept of the "Dalit feminist standpoint" (in which she argues that the Dalit woman's perspective is an epistemological privilege, because she lives at the deepest level of oppression) comes to life in poetry here -"A Dalit Woman" speaks from that place where all three oppression-systems converge.

## 6. Analysis of the Figures: Body-Politics

The bodily figures in all three poems are extraordinarily intense and varied.

In It is I Who Lost Everything -"they scratched and clawed and turned me into a hen" -this is a figure of animalization (turning a human into an animal). "Hen" -in the form of that animal which is plucked without resistance.

In I am Wearing Menstrual Cloth -"my mouth, / which keeps sweating, / knows what it means to live invisibly" -the mouth is here the site of both expression and suppression. Sweating = working = becoming visible. But society keeps the Dalit woman invisible.

In A Dalit Woman -"urinates in my joined hands" -this is the most raw, the most humiliated image. Hands joined in prayer -which are the symbol of reverence -urinating in them: this is the supreme humiliation of the sacred. Shashinirmala exercises no poetic restraint in this image -because reality itself is restraint-less.

Frantz Fanon's concept of the colonized body (in which he shows that colonialism first attacks the body -by humiliating, by controlling it -breaking the soul) applies simultaneously to all three poems here.

## 7. Language and Style: The Poetics of Aggression

Shashinirmala's language is more aggressive, more direct, and more confrontational than all previous poets. This aggressiveness has a literary-political significance.

Subhadra's language is meditative testimony -she sees and shows. Swarooparani's language is passionate proclamation -she speaks having broken open. Shashinirmala's language is direct accusation -she speaks naming, pointing a finger, looking eye to eye.

"They put a nose-ring in me and play with me" -the nose-ring is for animals, not humans. In this figure the politics of animalization (the social process of transforming the Dalit woman from human to animal) is stated directly.

"They milk me like a buffalo" -to show labor-exploitation in the figure of milking an animal -in this Marx's extraction of surplus value (the owner taking the value produced by the worker's labor) and caste exploitation are both contained in the same image.

## 8. Comparison with Previous Poets: A Comprehensive Poetic Genealogy

All four poets studied in this review series -Bhimanna, Subhadra, Swarooparani, and Shashinirmala -together create a complete poetic genealogy of Telugu Dalit poetry:

Bhimanna -history and the counter-reading of mythology; macro-vision; the restoration of Dalit identity.

Subhadra -labor, object, and motherhood; micro-vision; poetic archiving of daily life.

Swarooparani -transformation of personal consciousness; meso-vision (an intermediary vision between the personal and social); the dialectic of hope and despair.

Shashinirmala -three-fronted struggle; confrontational vision; exposing the contradictions within feminism.

These four together complete a dialectical journey -beginning with history (Bhimanna), descending into daily life (Subhadra), awakening personal consciousness (Swarooparani), and finally confronting from all sides (Shashinirmala).

## Conclusion

Darishee Shashinirmala's three poems take Dalit women's poetry onto a new political terrain. She says what is difficult to say -the oppression of Dalit men, the hypocrisy of upper-caste feminism, the caste-partisanship of the state apparatus -without any restraint, without any diplomacy.

In her poetry beauty lies in anger, craft lies in aggressiveness, philosophy lies in concrete bodily reality. This is the culmination of a tradition in Dalit women's poetics that draws its power from Sharankumar Limbale, Omprakash Valmiki, and the tradition of Ambedkar's thought.

The final line -"let's see what wonders they can show us" -is a challenge: the Dalit woman is no longer a spectator, she is a questioner. This question has been asked of society, of feminism, of the Dalit movement -of everyone. And answering this question -that is not the work of literature, but of history.

## Part VI: M. Gauri's Poem -Henna-Stained Hands

## Prefatory Note

M. Gauri is an entirely distinctive voice in the Telugu Dalit women's poetic tradition. While Shashinirmala writes a poetry of three-fronted struggle, Subhadra creates labor-object-poetry, and Bhimanna performs mythological counter-readings -Gauri adopts a strategy different from all of these: she directly addresses Krishna by inverting mythological narrative -and this dialogue becomes the poetic self-declaration of a Dalit cobbler woman.

In this single poem, the poetic complexity, counter-mythological reading, craft-skill, and political courage assembled are such that it places itself among the greatest works of Telugu Dalit poetry.

## 1. Poetic Form and Structure

### Direct Address Structure

This poem is composed in the second-person address -and that "you" is none other than Sri Krishna himself. This is an extraordinarily courageous poetic decision. In the Indian poetic tradition addressing Krishna is a long-standing tradition -Mirabai, Surdas, Jayadeva -but in all of those the speaker is a devotee, the relation is that of Krishna-superior and speaker-humble.

Gauri inverts this hierarchy. She addresses Krishna -but not as a devotee, but as a challenger. "Can you see it without fainting?", "Can you kiss my blood-stained hands?" -these are not devotion's questions, but questions of examination.

### Three-Tier Poetic Arc

The poem is divided into three distinct sections:

First section -from "My lane is made of flesh and blood" to "the game of piercing a sturdy bull straight through." Here the world of labor -the Dalit cobbler woman's daily work -is established.

Second section -from "You, O brave Krishna!" to "behind the curtain of skin-leather." Here the counter-mythological dialogue -questioning each of Krishna's three forms (destroyer of maya, lover of the gopis, player of the flute) -takes place.

Third section -from "My lane is no longer fit for pet puppies" to the end. Here the Dalit cobbler woman's self-declaration -the reclamation of her own labor, her own body, her own dignity -occurs.

This three-arc structure is a dialectical structure of thesis-antithesis-synthesis -but here synthesis is not a middle path, but a rebellious self-establishment.

2. The Counter-Mythological Reading: Questioning Krishna's Three Forms

In this single poem Gauri addresses three mythological forms of Krishna in sequence -and against all three she raises the Dalit woman's reality.

First Form: Krishna the Destroyer of Maya

"You, O brave Krishna! / who killed the demon mother by drinking her milk" -this is a reference to the Putana episode. In the Purana, Krishna kills Putana, who gives poison to suckle -this is a symbol of divine heroism.

Gauri challenges this "heroism": "I will show you two pieces of flesh and a vessel of blood. / Can you see it without fainting?" -the work the cobbler woman does daily -dealing with flesh and blood -is more real and more

courageous than Krishna's "heroism." This comparison of mythological heroism and the Dalit daily-labor is extremely bitter and extremely true.

Second Form: Krishna the Gopi-Lover

"You, who snatched the clothes of the gopis" -this is a reference to the cloth-theft episode which in the devotional tradition is considered divine play (lila).

Gauri reads this "divine play" from the perspective of sexual exploitation -and then challenges: "Can you steal my heart, / which I have kept safe -/ behind the curtain of skin-leather?" The heart is kept safe "behind the curtain of skin-leather" -this is an extraordinarily complex figure. Skin-leather = the cobbler woman's professional identity = which society considers "impure." That very "impure" identity becomes a protective shield -protecting from Krishna's love-conspiracy.

Third Form: Krishna the Flute-Player

"You, who sent love-messages through the flute, / can you read the love-message that I have written on the threshold with my gentle fingers?" -Krishna's flute is the symbol of divine love in devotional poetry. But here the cobbler woman's love-message written on the threshold is more concrete, more real, more human.

"Threshold" -door-step -is a symbol of boundary. The Dalit woman writes on the threshold -neither inside (the upper-caste home) nor outside. The love written on the threshold is marginal love (the experience of the margin).

The tradition of counter-mythological reading from Bhimanna (in which he re-read the personalities of the Mahabharata from the Dalit perspective) is here presented by Gauri in a more dramatic manner -as a poetic dialogue.

### 3. The Multi-Level Meaning of the Title

"Henna-Stained Hands" -this title is extraordinarily ambiguous (double-meaning).

First meaning -in Indian cultural tradition henna is a symbol of wedding celebration -adornment, auspiciousness, love. "Henna-stained hands" means festive hands.

Second meaning -within the poem, "henna" is actually blood. "Can you kiss my blood-stained hands, / without henna?" -here blood = henna. The blood on the cobbler woman's hands is the henna of labor -not of marriage.

This inverted symbol (inverting an auspicious symbol into a symbol of labor-reality) is an outstanding example of Dalit aesthetics. In upper-caste culture henna = beauty and celebration. In the cobbler Dalit woman's life henna = blood and labor. Gauri brings both meanings together in a single word.

### 4. The Leather Figure: Reclaiming Dalit Identity

The most powerful section of the poem is the final section -where leather (which society considers "impure") becomes the central reclamation-figure of the poem:

"When my leather is washed with Indian laburnum, / erasing the marks of your fingers -/ it becomes a drum, / resonating with pure music."

In these lines a three-level transformation occurs:

First -Krishna's finger-marks (those who snatched the gopis' clothes, who played the flute) are inscribed on the leather -that is, the stamp of upper-caste cultural claims is on the Dalit body.

Second -after washing with Indian laburnum (which Subhadra also used in Laanda), these marks are erased -that is, indigenous knowledge-tradition erases upper-caste cultural claims.

Third -the washed leather becomes a drum that resonates with pure music. This is of great importance: the leather that society considers "impure," from that same leather the drum produces "pure music."

This is the complete negation of the purity-impurity myth -not through argument, but through figure. Julia Kristeva's abjection theory finds a poetic answer here: Gauri transforms the "disgusting" into the "beautiful," the "impure" into "pure music."

## 5. The Play-Figure and Heroism

The poem begins with a poetic invitation -"Won't you come and play with me?" -which seems like an innocent children's invitation to play. But it immediately becomes clear that this play is about actually piercing a sturdy bull.

"Not the cowardly play of the ox in the procession, / I will show you a game of real heroism" -here there is a hierarchical comparison. Those who parade a castrated bull in a religious procession -that is "cowardly play." The cobbler Dalit woman's work -piercing a sturdy bull -is real heroism.

Jallikattu (bull-wrestling) in Indian folk tradition is a game of displaying heroism. Gauri, by making this folk tradition a figure of Dalit-woman labor, challenges the upper-caste cultural definition of heroism: real heroism is not in the religious procession, but in daily labor.

## 6. "Without Bent Spine": Poetic Declaration of Dalit Dignity

"Come, / if you can come, / I will teach you to pick up bones -/ I will show you a spine that has not bent."

This line is the philosophical-political essence of the entire poem.

"Picking up bones" -the cobbler woman's professional work -here assumes the form of knowledge transfer. She wants to teach Krishna. Teacher the Dalit woman, student Krishna -this is the complete inversion of the hierarchy.

"Spine that has not bent" -here there is a double meaning. Literal meaning: an animal's vertebral column that is straight, that has not bent. Figurative meaning: the Dalit woman's self-respect that has not bent.

Babasaheb Ambedkar used to say: "It is more important that a life be great than that it be long." Gauri's Dalit woman is not long-lived -she is indomitable.

## 7. "Not Sin" -Negating Religious Morality

"It is not a sin of the water turned to earth, / It is not a sin of the 'criminal' skin."

"Criminal skin" -here the quotation marks are important. The society that calls skin "criminal" -that is the society's false morality. Gauri directly rejects this morality.

In Brahmanical religious scripture, the cobbler's work is considered sin -the fruit of the karma of a previous birth. Gauri directly negates this karma theory: "It is not a sin." These two words -"not sin" -are a poetic manifesto against the entire Brahmanical moral-economic system.

Friedrich Nietzsche's revaluation of values (in which he argues that prevailing morality is not truth, but rules created in the interest of those in power) echoes here -but Gauri arrives at this conclusion not by reading Nietzsche, but from the reality of life.

## 8. Water Figure: A New Definition of Purity

"When water becomes steam and turns into a cloud in the sky to rain drops of lightning, / the purity of the lane becomes transparent."

In these lines physical science and poetic figure become one. When water becomes steam -it becomes invisible. Then transforming into cloud it rains lightning -it assumes the form of power. The Dalit woman's lane that society considers "impure" -its purity becomes "transparent" i.e. clear when this transformation occurs. Transparency = the revelation of truth.

In this figure there is a poetic representation of Hegelian dialectics (in which new truth arises from the conflict of opposing elements) -but here it is not abstract philosophy, it is the concrete reality of earth and water.

## 9. Comparison with Bhimanna: Two Forms of Counter-Mythological Reading

Bhimanna's My Ancestral Rights and Gauri's Henna-Stained Hands -both perform a counter-reading of mythology. But the strategy differs:

Bhimanna shows the historical argument of mythology -Vyasa, Vasishtha, Matsyagandhi were actually of Dalit origin, revealing this historical truth. His strategy is scholarly counter-reading.

Gauri engages in dramatic dialogue with mythology -speaks directly to Krishna, challenges him, invites him to her lane. Her strategy is poetic confrontation.

Both together present the complete spectrum of counter-mythological reading in Dalit poetry -attacking through argument and attacking through dialogue.

10. Consonance with Subhadra's Laanda: The Symbol of the Drum

As mentioned above, both Subhadra's Laanda and Gauri's Henna-Stained Hands contain the symbol of the drum. But in different contexts:

In Laanda -"for creaking shoes and making drums -/ he beats a sweet rhythm on that drum" -the drum is a symbol of the husband's art. The woman's labor transforms into the husband's art -in this there is the bitterness of labor-alienation.

In Henna-Stained Hands -the drum is a symbol of the Dalit woman's own identity. Her body, her labor, her leather -these are all the source of pure music. Here there is no labor-alienation -there is labor-celebration.

The different use of the drum in both poems demonstrates the polyphony of a single symbol in Dalit women's poetry.

### Conclusion

M. Gauri's Henna-Stained Hands is a pinnacle work of Telugu Dalit poetry. In this single poem:

Mythological and modern are one -Krishna and the cobbler woman stand in the same place.

Craft and politics are one -the beauty of the figure and the social accusation are in the same breath.

Personal and collective are one -one woman's voice becomes the voice of the entire Dalit cobbler community.

At the end -"it becomes a drum, / resonating with pure music" -what Gauri says is: the Dalit woman's body, labor, and identity -which society calls "impure" -is in fact the source of the purest music. This is not merely a poetic figure -it is a complete civilizational vision.

## Part VII: Madduri Vijayashri's Poem -Alisamma's Curse

### Prefatory Note

Madduri Vijayashri's Alisamma's Curse is an extraordinary poetic achievement in the Telugu Dalit women's poetic tradition. In this short poem -in merely thirty-odd lines -so much poetic complexity, such historical-mythological density, and such political courage are assembled that it occupies a distinctive position in its own class.

In this poem three time-periods are simultaneously present: the Ramayana-era (the cutting of Shurpanakha's nose), contemporary history (the real event of Alisamma), and the present (the contemporary crisis of Dalit women). This tri-temporal unity creates an extraordinary poetic compression of time in the poem.

1. Poetic Form and Structure

Initial Foreshadowing

The poem's first three lines -"You may find this strange, / You may find this laughable, / You may find this very repulsive" -are an anaphoric series that anticipates three different reader-responses.

This structure is highly calculated. The poet knows that her poem will be read by three types of readers: those who find it strange (liberals), those who laugh (cynics), those who are disgusted (reactionaries). By addressing all three at once the poet makes clear -"But now I am a new question" -irrespective of any response, the poem's existence is unshakeable.

Structure of Self-Introduction

The middle section of the poem is a progressive self-introduction -from negative to positive:

First -what she is not: cannot sit in the reserved seat, has no honorific title.

Second -what she is: sorrow, rolling, victim of lust.

Third -naming: "I am Alisamma" -at this line the poem enters a new level.

This structure is the poem's journey from definition by negation to self-declaration -which ultimately transforms into a proclamation of curse.

The Final Explosion

The final section -"You beasts! / I curse you all" -is an abrupt change of register. The entire poem that had proceeded in a measured, analytical voice -it suddenly transforms into an aggressive roar here. This is a poetic earthquake.

2. Alisamma: Historical Person and Poetic Symbol

In Shashinirmala's I am Wearing Menstrual Cloth, Alisamma's mention had occurred -but there she was merely a mention by name. Vijayashri here makes Alisamma the speaker of the poem -she herself speaks.

Alisamma is a real historical person -a Dalit woman in Andhra Pradesh who was stripped naked and paraded in public by upper-caste men. This event became a symbolic event of Dalit women's oppression.

Vijayashri, by making this historical person the poetic speaker, accomplishes two tasks simultaneously:

First -she transforms Alisamma from object to subject. In history she was a victim whose story others told. Here she speaks herself.

Second -she makes Alisamma universal. "I am Alisamma" -in this the "I" is not merely one individual, but all Dalit women.

Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's question "Can the Subaltern Speak?" (can the subordinate class be present in history in its own voice?) is answered here by Vijayashri: Yes -in this poem. Alisamma is speaking.

## 3. The Mythological-Historical Parallel: Shurpanakha and Alisamma

The most courageous poetic decision in the poem is -linking the cutting of Shurpanakha's nose and Alisamma's public stripping in the same line:

"First my ears and nose were cut at Lord Ram's command. / Now just recently, / I became suffering in police hands without reason."

In this parallelism there are many layers of meaning:

First level -in both events the oppressor is a man and the victim is a Dalit/excluded woman. Shurpanakha is of demon lineage -the social "other." Alisamma is of Dalit lineage -the social "other."

Second level -in both events state power is a participant in oppression. At Ram's command, Lakshmana cuts the nose. By police hands, Alisamma suffers. The religious-state (Ramayana-era) and the modern state -both do the same thing.

Third level -in the Ramayana, Shurpanakha's desire was treated as crime -she had wanted to marry Ram or Lakshmana. Alisamma's existence was treated as crime. In both events, woman's desire or woman's presence becomes the cause of oppression.

Fourth level -"Lord Ram" -here "Lord" is ironic. He who is "Lord" (God, protector) commands the oppression of women. This is the negation of religion-based morality.

The tradition of Bhimanna's counter-mythological reading (in which he re-read the Mahabharata's personalities) goes further in this poem. Bhimanna re-read

history -Vijayashri shows by connecting history to the present that nothing has changed.

4. The Philosophy of "New Question"

"But now I am a new question" -this line is of utmost importance.

In traditional philosophy a question is a means, an answer is the goal. In the Socratic method questions lead towards truth. But Vijayashri says: I myself am the question.

This is an existentialist declaration. The Dalit woman is not an answer -she is herself a question -for society, for the system, for history. As long as the Dalit woman is alive, the question will not end.

Simone de Beauvoir's "otherness" in The Second Sex (in which she argues that woman has always been the "other" -defined in relation to man) becomes more complex here with the Dalit-caste dimension. The Dalit woman is not "other" -she is a question -that demands an answer.

5. The Poetic-Political Importance of "Curse"

The title and final declaration -"curse" -is extraordinarily multi-layered.

Curse in Religious Tradition

In the Hindu religious tradition, the curse of sages and ascetics is considered extremely powerful. Brahma's curse, Durvasa's curse -these are irrevocable. The right to curse has always belonged to upper-caste men.

Vijayashri gives this right to curse into the hands of the Dalit woman. This is an inversion of the hierarchy: she who always received curses -now gives them.

The Content of the Curse

"I curse you all that you will be turned into humans -/ breaking and reforming your tails and pointed teeth."

This curse is extraordinarily unusual. Ordinarily a curse is destructive -die, be reduced to ashes, become an animal. Vijayashri's curse is transformative -become human.

In this there is a profound philosophical sarcasm: those who are the oppressors -police, upper-castes, those who behave like animals -are actually animals. To curse them to become human -this is the supreme irony.

In this there is an echo of Frantz Fanon's anti-colonial philosophy -where he argues that the colonist/oppressor has actually lost their humanity. The victim is more humane, the oppressor less. Vijayashri transforms this argument into a poetic curse.

6. The Absence of Honorific Title

"When spoken to or called out to, / there is no honorific title before or after my name."

This line exposes the relationship between language and social identity. In Indian society names are preceded or followed -"Shrimati," "Doctor," "Late," caste-indicating surname -these are all marks of social recognition.

When the Dalit woman speaks or calls out -she is nameless. Neither "Shrimati" (married honor), nor caste-surname (which gives social place), nor professional title.

The linguist Pierre Bourdieu's concept of linguistic capital (in which he shows that social power-relations are reflected in language) applies here. The right to naming is a social power. Before and after the Dalit woman's name is zero -this emptiness is the symbol of her absence in society.

7. The Figure of the Reserved Seat

"Even though it is empty, / I cannot sit in the seat reserved for women."

This line is an extraordinarily precise poetic presentation of contemporary Dalit women's experience. Bus, train, office -the "Women Reserved" seat is theoretically for all women. But in practice the Dalit woman cannot sit on it -because upper-caste women or men object.

In this figure the distinction between law and reality is revealed. The Indian Constitution guarantees equality -but in social reality this guarantee is like an empty seat -present, but inaccessible.

Swarooparani's stigmatization through reservations (humiliation by calling "she came from quota") and Vijayashri's inaccessibility of reserved seat -both together demonstrate the contradiction between the Dalit woman's constitutional rights and social reality.

8. "Lighting a Wick in Court's Eye"

"I am Alisamma, / who lit a wick in the eye of the court."

This figure carries extraordinary poetic density.

"Court's eye" -in the symbol of justice the blindfolded goddess (Justitia, eye-bandaged) exists in the Western tradition -saying justice is impartial. But in the Indian context the court has been partial to caste-class.

"Lighting a wick in the eye" -ordinarily lighting a lamp's wick is spreading light. But lighting a wick in the eye is torment. Alisamma going to court -which should be for obtaining justice -becomes a torture experience.

In this figure there is both hope and irony: Alisamma went to court to bring light -but in that "eye" the wick burned, kept burning.

9. "Still Alive as Woman and Dalit Both"

This line is the essence-sentence of Dalit women's poetry.

"Both" -this single word encompasses the entire history of oppression. Oppression as a woman. Oppression as a Dalit. Both together. "Both" says: despite all this.

This is the political act of living. Paul Gilroy considers "living, laughing, loving" a form of cultural resistance against oppression. Vijayashri's "still alive" -in this sense -living itself is rebellion.

## 10. All Five Poets: A Final Synthesis

In this entire review series we have studied five Telugu Dalit poets -Bhimanna, Subhadra, Swarooparani, Shashinirmala, Gauri, and Vijayashri. All together create a complete Dalit-women's poetic universe:

Bhimanna -Mirror of History. Counter-reading of mythology and history.

Subhadra -Mirror of Labor. Poetic archiving of the concrete world of objects in daily life.

Swarooparani -Mirror of Consciousness. The journey of personal transformation.

Shashinirmala -Mirror of Struggle. Three-fronted struggle from three-fronted oppression.

Gauri -Mirror of Identity. Transformation of "impure" identity into pure music.

Vijayashri -Mirror of Justice. Making the victim of history the speaker, making the curse into a weapon.

These six mirrors together create the complete reflection of the Dalit woman's existence.

## Conclusion

Madduri Vijayashri's Alisamma's Curse is the supreme poetic moment of this entire Telugu Dalit poetry series.

In this poem:

History speaks -Alisamma, who was an object, becomes the speaker.

Mythology is shattered -Ram's "lordship" and the police's "authority" are joined in the same line.

Language rebels -"curse" -which was the privilege of the upper-caste -becomes the Dalit woman's weapon.

Philosophy is born -living is rebellion, becoming a question is power.

The final line -"breaking and reforming your tails and pointed teeth" -is a demand of the future. As long as the oppressor does not abandon their animality, the curse will remain active. This demand is addressed to society, to the system, to history -to everyone.

And this question -"Now I am a new question" -is the final, unanswered, and most powerful voice of this entire Telugu Dalit poetry series.

## Part VIII: Gujarati Dalit Poetry -Four Poems

Anish Garange, Rajendra Vadel 'Jeeta', Umesh Solanki

### Prefatory Note

The Gujarati Dalit poetry presented in this collection -following the Telugu tradition -is poetic expression of Dalit experience on a different linguistic-cultural terrain. While the Dalit-woman voice was prominent in the Telugu poems, here the Dalit-male voice is more central -but in Vadel's Sambhog the Dalit-woman reality reappears.

The three poets -Garange, Vadel, Solanki -adopt three different poetic strategies: Garange uses urban realism (the concrete, sensory reality of city life), Vadel uses sexual-political testimony, and Solanki uses freeze-figures and anti-Gandhi irony. These three together create a complete urban-political picture of Gujarati Dalit poetry.

1. Anish Garange: Poster

Poetic Form and Structure

Poster is composed in a circular structure (in which the first line becomes the last). "These rough-faced posters are like a mirror to me" -the poem begins with this and ends with this. This circular structure symbolically expresses the endless cycle of Dalit existence -from which there is no exit.

The lines in the middle -cinema banners, advertisements, condolence meetings, toilets, rallies, railway stations, rickshaws, missing-person posters -these are all fragments of urban life. Structurally this is collage-poetry (the poetic technique of creating meaning by assembling seemingly unrelated pieces).

The Multi-Layered Nature of the Poster-Figure

"Poster" in this poem is extraordinarily multi-meaning:

First meaning -a poster is temporary. It is pasted one day, peeled off by morning. Dalit existence is also, in society's eyes, temporary, replaceable.

Second meaning -a poster is public -everyone sees it, no one pays attention. The Dalit person is also visible but invisible.

Third meaning -a poster is polymorphous -cinema, advertisement, political rally, missing person -all kinds of posters exist. The Dalit person is also used by various social institutions for various purposes.

"Mirror" (aina) -the most important figure of the poem. The poster that is the Dalit's "mirror" -this is irony. A mirror gives an authentic reflection. But a poster is a distorted, humiliated, purpose-constructed image. That is: the "mirror" that society shows the Dalit -is a false mirror.

Jacques Lacan's mirror stage (in which he argues that the child, seeing its reflection in the mirror, constructs its "I") applies here negatively. The "mirror" (poster) that the Dalit person sees presents a distorted self-image -imposed by society.

Urban Realism

"In 'pay-and-use' toilets you urinate on me" -this line is extremely direct. The "pay-and-use toilet" -a concrete urban space -is here a figure of social humiliation. There is a right to enter the toilet for money -but urinating on the Dalit is free.

"I am a ball of useless paper" -this is self-objectification (treating oneself as an object) -but this self-objectification comes not from self-hatred, but from acceptance of social reality. The poem says: this is how society sees me.

"Khaman-Khari" -this Gujarati food item is here a cultural-geographic identity. "A face smeared with Khaman-Khari" -the middle-class-upper-caste image of

Gujarati culture (Khaman-dhokla that has become the symbolic food of Gujarat) is smeared on the Dalit face -humiliatingly, sardonically.

Walter Benjamin's urban experience (in which he argues that the modern city dissolves the human into a mass of objects) becomes more complex in the Dalit-urban experience: the city not only anonymizes but also constructs caste-stigma.

2. Rajendra Vadel 'Jeeta': Sambhog (Intercourse)

Poetic Form: Sexual-Political Testimony

Sambhog is the Gujarati counterpart of the sexual-political voice of Shashinirmala in the Telugu Dalit poetry series -but with an important difference: here the speaker is male, and the poem analyzes the physical relationship between the upper-caste man and the Dalit woman.

This is an extraordinarily courageous poetic decision. Sexual relations are generally considered a private subject. Vadel makes this the subject of political analysis.

The "Foul-Smelling" Body

"Your body was fouled from your ancestors who crushed Dalit women" -this line is extraordinarily complex.

"Fouled" -the Dalit caste is generally called "impure" and "foul-smelling." Vadel inverts this pollution-stigma: the upper-caste body is fouled by the history of rape of Dalit women.

"From ancestors" -this word is important. This is not a personal sin -it is historical exploitation passed down from generation to generation. In the upper-caste man's body, the deeds of those ancestors are materially present.

In Vadel's these lines there is a poetic representation of epigenetics (in which science shows that the ancestor's experience leaves an effect on the descendant's biology). And with this, Fanon's concept of the colonized body (in which he shows that the history of violence is inscribed in the colonizer's body).

The Final Declaration: "Bharat" and "Bharati"

"If from our intercourse a son is born / name him 'Bharat' / if a daughter, 'Bharati'."

This is the most explosive line in the poem. Several levels of meaning are simultaneously present:

First level -"Bharat" and "Bharati" are names of national identity -national symbols. Calling the child of the Dalit woman and upper-caste man "Bharat" -this reveals the true history of nation-building. The Indian nation is the product of this caste-sexual violence.

Second level -in the nationalist imagination of "Bharat Mata," the mother is upper-caste, pure. Vadel shows that the real "Bharat Mata" is the Dalit woman -upon whose body the nation's history was written.

Third level -"if a son" / "if a daughter" -this hypothetical sentence-construction is a demand of the future: accept this truth.

B.R. Ambedkar argued in Annihilation of Caste that the permanence of caste depends on endogamy (where the upper caste marries within its own caste). Vadel's poem inverts this argument: the abolition of caste begins not merely with marriage, but with acknowledging the history of caste-violence.

3. Umesh Solanki: People, Freeze!

Poetic Form: Extension of the Freeze-Figure

People, Freeze! is based on a single extended metaphor. "Freeze" -this simple physical action -becomes a complex political figure in the poem.

The structure is anaphoric (repeatedly beginning with the same phrase) -the repetition of "freeze" gives the poem a mantra-quality. But this mantra is not devotion -it is revolutionary.

The Political Philosophy of "Freezing"

The "freeze" that Solanki wants -is not against stability, but a demand for change through stability.

"Let the tea in the kettle freeze" -tea is a symbol of movement, heat -made and drunk every day. Its freezing = the stopping of daily normalcy.

"Let the soft fingers go cold and freeze like dead sea-shells at the mere touch of a coin" -"coin" (money) and "soft fingers" -a figure of capitalist labor-exploitation. The fingers that touch money turn to dead stone -capital turns humans to stone.

"To clear this thick blanket of fog" -"fog" -a figure of ignorance, delusion, lies. The social delusion by which Dalit oppression seems normal -that "fog" will only clear through freezing -that is, through a radical stop.

Marx's accumulated labor (in which he argues that capital is actually the worker's accumulated labor that passes into the owner's hands) is in poetic

dialogue with Solanki's "freezing": if labor "freezes" -that is, strikes -the system collapses that rests on this labor.

4. Umesh Solanki: All the Broom-Sticks

Poetic Form: Sarcastic Address

All the Broom-Sticks is a direct address poem -speaking directly to Gandhiji. In this poetic technique there is resemblance to Gauri's Henna-Stained Hands (address to Krishna) and Vijayashri's Alisamma's Curse (address to the oppressor).

But this poem's address is singular: Gandhi -who claimed to be the Dalit's "Mahatma" (well-wisher) -to him anger and disappointment expressed directly.

The Poetic Representation of the Gandhi-Ambedkar Conflict

The Gandhi-Ambedkar controversy was India's most important political-philosophical controversy. Gandhi wanted, calling Dalits "Harijans," to lift them within the Hindu system through reform. Ambedkar completely rejected this system at its roots.

Solanki brings this historical controversy into poetry:

"Your khadi wears out very quickly" -khadi is Gandhi's symbol -Swadeshi, simplicity, nationality. "Wearing out" = the hollowness of the symbol being revealed. Gandhi's ideals proved not durable in Dalit life.

"You must surely be hating the life locked in a frame on the wall" -in government offices, schools, homes -Gandhi's picture is locked in a frame. This

"frame" is a symbol of institutionalization -turning Gandhi into a museum-object, so that his real ideas have no effect on society.

"Who are you smiling for?" -this question is extremely sharp. There is a smile in Gandhi's picture. But in the lives of the Dalit community he claimed to work for -there is no reason to smile. For whom is that smile?

"The Broom-Sticks"

The title -"All the Broom-Sticks" -is extraordinarily multi-meaning. The "broom" was the symbol of Gandhi's cleanliness movement -Swadeshi, simplicity, nationality. But "broom-sticks" (the broom's handle) -what remains when the broom wears out.

The poem shows these remnants -the people left behind by the cleanliness movement: "in the city's secret lanes the sweepings of broom-handles -/ they grumble / they groan."

This "grumbling" and "groaning" -the Dalit sanitation workers who were left outside Gandhi's "cleanliness" movement -these are their words of torment.

July 2009: Historical Context

At the poem's end there is a contextual note: the liquor tragedy in Ahmedabad in July 2009. In this event, mainly Dalit workers died after drinking spurious liquor.

Gandhi was anti-liquor. Gujarat is a prohibition state -the land of Gandhi's ideals. But in that "Gandhian" state, Dalit workers die from spurious liquor.

"Gandhi / I pour liquor on your head" -this line is extremely aggressive. Liquor on Gandhi's head -which was his greatest prohibition -pouring it: this is complete rejection.

"Shame / may the bag of liquor go over your skull" -this is a curse -like Vijayashri's Alisamma's Curse. But here the curse is more ironic: liquor -which was against Gandhi -on Gandhi.

B.R. Ambedkar's Gandhi-criticism -that Gandhi was doing politics in the name of Dalits but was not fundamentally changing the caste system -takes poetic form in Solanki's poem.

## 5. Comparative Analysis: Telugu versus Gujarati

Comparing these Gujarati poems with the Telugu tradition, several important differences and similarities emerge:

Urban-centricity: Telugu Dalit poetry is generally connected to rural-agricultural reality -field, paddy, landlord. Gujarati poetry is urban-centric -railway station, rickshaw, toilet, advertisement. This demonstrates the geographic diversity of Dalit experience.

Male voice: In the Telugu Dalit poetry series, the women's voice was dominant. In the Gujarati collection all three poets are male. This reveals the different forms of regional Dalit movements.

Gandhi episode: Gandhi's mention is generally absent in Telugu Dalit poetry. In Gujarati Dalit poetry -written in Gandhi's home state -the Gandhi-Ambedkar controversy is central. This is the entry of local history into poetry.

Poetic language: Indigenous symbols (Indian laburnum, tamarind, Maisamma Devi) abound in Telugu poetry. Urban-modern symbols (poster, advertisement, pay-and-use toilet) predominate in Gujarati poetry.

## 6. Special Note on the Translation Series

These poems made the journey of Gujarat → English (Hemang Desai) → Maithili. An important difference from the Telugu poems' translation: the Telugu → English translation was done by Purushottam K., the Gujarati → English by Hemang Desai.

Hemang Desai is himself a scholar of Gujarati Dalit literature -this was the work of an insider translator (who is also a member of the culture from which the translation is made). From this culturally-specific references (like "Khaman-Khari," "Kharda") were translated with greater authenticity.

## Conclusion

These four Gujarati Dalit poems together present a complete picture of urban Dalit experience:

Garange's Poster -poetry of the Dalit existence's invisibility and distorted visibility.

Vadel's Sambhog -poetry connecting the history of caste-sexual violence to nation-building.

Solanki's People, Freeze! -poetry of radical stopping, of strike, of systemic halt.

Solanki's All the Broom-Sticks -poetry of the contradiction between Gandhism and Dalit reality.

All four together create a poetic manifesto: the modern Indian state -its symbols (Gandhi, national flag, Constitution) and its institutions (police, court, media) -has failed to deliver justice to Dalit existence.

And as long as this failure continues, Dalit poetry -in Telugu, in Gujarati, in Maithili -will continue questioning, bearing witness, and cursing.

## Part IX: Odia Dalit Poetry -Basudev Sunani's Three Poems

### Still Much Remains to Be Done, Address, and Sadananda

#### Prefatory Note

Basudev Sunani is a distinctive and complex voice in Odia Dalit poetry. Different from Telugu and Gujarati Dalit poetry -in which direct political proclamation or personal pain's testimony was at the center -Sunani's poetry expresses the Dalit experience through mystical and philosophical dimensions. His poetic language is full of figurative density -in which a drop, a seed, a fish, an egret, the sea -these natural-cosmic images become the poetic expression of the Dalit identity's invisibility and struggle.

This collection contains three related poetic sections -Still Much Remains to Be Done, Address, and Sadananda -which together present a three-dimensional poetic argument: the warning of existence, the invisibility of existence, and the innocence and irony of existence.

#### 1. Poetic Form and Structure

Still Much Remains to Be Done

In this poem two refrain lines appear repeatedly -"Still I feel I don't know why / that just at the corner / something is hanging and swaying" -at the poem's beginning and middle. This repetition creates a sense of permanent uncertainty -as if something were incomplete, as if some explosion were yet to occur.

The structure is based on paradoxical pairs: "the bell's sound" versus "the drum's explosion," "the collection of sticks and leaves" versus "the house's demolition," "Paanchajanya" versus "the smallest reaction." These pairs show the bipolar tension of Dalit identity -invisibility and explosion.

Address

In this poem the structure is that of fragmented self-portrayal. "I am still..." -this line comes three times, in three different forms:

First -an old woman (who carries a lamp in a wedding procession). Second -a sick old man (who begs in front of a temple). Third -a sleeping child (lying on a step in the cold).

These three are the three generations of Dalit existence -elderly, adult, infant -all living in the same invisibility.

"And yet you want my address! / Strange!" -this sardonic astonishment (the poet is himself amazed that an address is demanded when his existence is everywhere) is the emotional center of the entire poem.

Sadananda

This poem's structure is a dramatic monologue -a real person, Sadananda, who came to a farmers' fair in the capital city, sees the sea. This simple-realistic structure is different from both previous poems.

But within this simplicity a deep political question is hidden: "Why should famine not strike my region? / When all the water is mortgaged to the sea."

2. "Paanchajanya" and "Vajra": Dalit Use of Mythological Figures

"I know that here no voice / is less than 'Paanchajanya.' / The smallest reaction / roars like a thunderbolt."

"Paanchajanya" -Krishna's conch -which signaled the beginning of the Mahabharata war. In this figure the Dalit voice is compared to Krishna's conch.

Bhimanna's counter-mythological reading tradition is here used by Sunani in a different way: he does not oppose the mythological symbol, he borrows it -and says that the Dalit voice is no less than that sacred sound.

This is a strategy of reclamation. Bhimanna used to say: the mythology's history was written incorrectly. Sunani says: our voice is equal to that mythology's supreme symbol.

3. Drop, Seed, and Pregnant Woman: Three Figures of Hope

In the final section of Still Much Remains to Be Done three hope-images come simultaneously:

"Here in the sky there is such a drop / which though indistinct shines / and dreaming a sweet dream of a rainbow / has vowed again and again / to color the vast sky."

"Here a seed has vowed to germinate / with the wish to make everything green."

"And here in sadness / an abandoned pregnant woman / is searching for a quiet moment -/ to give birth to a child / who can face and stop seven warriors."

These three images are a series of progressively increasing power: drop → seed → mother of warriors.

Drop -most tiny, indistinct. But it dreams of a rainbow -aspiration for vastness within smallness.

Seed -larger than drop. It vows to germinate -not a passive wish, but an active resolve.

Pregnant woman -most powerful. She is "abandoned" -left by society. But she awaits birth of a child who can face seven warriors.

The echo of the Dalit women poets of the Telugu tradition resonates in this image of the abandoned pregnant woman -Subhadra's "Avva", Swarooparani's "Hands Turned to Earth". But Sunani makes this woman the mother of a future revolution.

4. Address Poem: The Paradox of Invisibility and Omnipresence

The central paradox of the Address poem is: the Dalit existence is present everywhere -but invisible.

"From beginning to end / my presence / spreads like a shimmering line of ants / and resonates like the sound of cymbals."

"A line of ants" -minute, infinite, industrious -but no one pays attention. "The sound of cymbals" -sound is present, no one listens.

"For my address / you don't need to send a parcel now / with the address 'Care of the Sun or Moon'."

This line is extraordinarily sarcastic. Society wants to find the Dalit -but in the wrong place. Sun-moon -that is, abstract, philosophical, spiritual places -it searches. While the Dalit is in "that very dark lane" -in concrete, material, daily places.

In this, Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's "invisibility of the subaltern" (in which she argues that the intellectual-class wants to find the Dalit but in that place where they are not) takes poetic form.

"If you can / please send me -/ beautiful dreams filled with sunshine."

This is a reversed demand. The Dalit does not give an address -he demands dreams. This is irony: society that demands the Dalit's address -itself gives no dreams to the Dalit.

5. The Fish Figure: On the Edge of Extinction

"I swim like a small dream-laden fish / in the fistful of water of a disappearing pond."

This figure connects environmental and social destruction in a single image. The pond is disappearing -this is the reference to India's agricultural water-

crisis. The fish -which is the traditional livelihood of Dalit castes -lives in "a fistful of water."

"Dream-laden fish" -this image is both extraordinarily beautiful and sad. The fish has dreams -but the pond is drying up.

In Umesh Solanki's People, Freeze! the "freeze" was a demand for change. Sunani's "disappearing pond" -shows the result of change's absence.

"Should I plunge into the sea to give it nectar / or dig deep and push Vasuki serpent's gentle head / that holds the world in balance?"

This is a mythological dilemma. Vasuki serpent -who became rope in the churning of the ocean -holds the world in balance. The Dalit person asks: should I give nectar to the system (that is, contribute) or shake the system (push Vasuki)?

This is the philosophical question of revolution versus cooperation -which is the fundamental question of the entire Dalit political-philosophical tradition.

6. Sadananda: Short Story-Poem and Farmer's Vision

Sadananda is an entirely different voice in this series. While in the previous two poems a poetic "I" -an abstract, collective Dalit-consciousness -was the speaker, here a concrete individual -with name, village, reason -is present.

"My name is Sadananda. / My village's name is Nagaon. / I have come to Bhubaneswar for the farmers' fair / to receive the Governor's prize for the biggest okra."

This self-introduction is extremely simple and extremely profound. In literature, the Dalit character is generally nameless, collective. Giving Sadananda a name, village, and achievement -this is the politics of personhood.

"The biggest okra" -this detail seems amusing. But in it is a deep irony: the farmer who works in the field all year, their highest honor is "the biggest okra." This is both the devaluation of agricultural labor and the portrayal of the farmer's simplicity.

The Irony of the Sea-View

"Having seen the sea you said / that I did not understand / rather I understood wrongly -/ the waves."

Sadananda sees the sea for the first time. The urban intellectual (the "you") says -you didn't understand. Sadananda acknowledges: "Perhaps / I understood wrongly."

But at the poem's end this "misunderstanding" becomes a revelation of truth:

"Why should famine not strike my region? / When all the water is mortgaged to the sea."

Sadananda "misunderstood" the sea -but in his "misunderstanding" there is a political truth that the intellectual cannot see. The sea -which is grand, vast, and admired -is in reality the one holding the farmer's water as mortgage.

This epistemological inversion (in which the "uneducated" farmer's vision proves sharper than the "educated" intellectual's) is of utmost importance. Ganesh Devy's "After Amnesia" (in which he argues that oral-folk tradition's knowledge is many times superior to book-knowledge) finds poetic evidence here.

## 7. "Being Cut by the Egret": Playfulness and Disruption

"But engrossed in playfulness / at the most inauspicious moment / I am cut by the egret."

"Egret" -a predatory bird -that eats fish. In the context of the fish-figure (in which Dalit existence was fish) -"being cut by the egret" = being destroyed by the system.

"Engrossed in playfulness" -this is irony: exactly when the Dalit person feels free, joyful -then the blow comes.

In this image the uncertainty of Dalit life's poetic truth: joy is always temporary, crisis always comes suddenly.

## 8. Comparative Analysis: Odia versus Telugu-Gujarati

Mysticism versus Realism: Telugu Dalit poetry (especially Subhadra, Shashinirmala) is bitterly realistic -concrete, sensory. Sunani's poetry is full of mystical-natural images -drop, seed, fish, rainbow. This is the influence of the Odia poetic tradition which has a long tradition of nature-images.

Optimism versus Pessimism: In Gujarati poetry (especially Solanki's People, Freeze!) there is revolutionary exhortation. In Sunani's poetry hope and doubt are both simultaneously -the drop sees a rainbow but the pond dries up.

Individuality versus Collectivity: In Sadananda a concrete individual is present -who is mostly an anonymous "I" in Telugu-Gujarati poetry. This is the commitment to personhood in Odia poetry.

Intellectual-Farmer Controversy: The dialogue of "you" (urban intellectual) and "I" (farmer) in Sadananda -this is absent in Telugu-Gujarati poetry. Sunani brings this intra-Dalit class-controversy into poetry.

## Conclusion

Basudev Sunani's three poetic sections -Still Much Remains to Be Done, Address, Sadananda -present a distinctive philosophical-poetic tradition of Odia Dalit poetry.

In the first section -warning: something remains to be done, an explosion is coming.

In the second section -evidence: I am everywhere but invisible, my address is in "the dark lane."

In the third section -irony: Sadananda "misunderstood" -but in his misunderstanding there is truth that the intellectual cannot see.

All three together present a complete Dalit philosophy of existence: I exist (evidence), I will bring change (warning), I see truth through my own vision (negation through irony).

The final line -"Because I still remain in that dark lane / where I always was. / Always." -is the most quiet and most powerful final word of this entire collection, and perhaps of all Indian Dalit poetry.

"Always" -in this single word lies the entire weight of history, present, and invisibility.

## Part X: Dalit Short Fiction -Two Telugu Works

## The Crow by Kolakuri Enoch and Black Ink by Vinodini

### Prefatory Note

In this review series we have studied poetry so far. Now two short stories -The Crow and Black Ink -are presented. These two works represent the prose tradition of Dalit literature, and demonstrate the distinctive power of a narrative medium different from poetry.

Between the two stories there is a poetic paradox: The Crow is the story of external reality -community, ritual, power-relations; Black Ink is the story of internal reality -personal relationship, child-psychology, and the caste's moment-to-moment revelation. Together they reveal both the external and internal dimensions of Dalit experience.

### 1. The Crow: Narrative Structure and Craft

#### Narrative Perspective

The story is written from the third-person omniscient perspective -but this omniscience is selective. The narrator knows Avva's mental state, Bandodu's history, the crows' behavior -but never passes judgment. This detached narration creates a distinctive narrative effect: the reader judges for themselves.

Timeline and Information

The story's structure is in medias res (beginning from the middle of events) -the crows are already cawing, Bandodu is already at work. Background information -Bandodu's caste, their practice, the family's plight -is gradually, naturally revealed within the story.

This delayed exposition technique first draws the reader onto the story's surface -the crow's commotion, Bandodu's presence -and then slowly social complexity is revealed.

The Three-Level Structure

First level -Event: the crows caw, the hut is surrounded, Bandodu demands food.

Second level -Social explanation: Bandodu's caste, their practice, the crow-Bandodu relationship, the Madiga community's response.

Third level -Philosophical question: are liberation and curse the same thing? Are the crow and Bandodu enemies or family?

2. The Crow: Bandodu -A Unique Literary Character

Bandodu is a unique character in Telugu Dalit literature -and perhaps in all Indian literature. He is the lowest among the Dalits -the tenth sub-caste, living only by begging from the Madigas.

The Character's Paradox

Bandodu is powerless -a beggar, the lowest of caste. But he is also powerful -"more powerful than a stubborn king," controlling the crows, holding an entire community hostage.

This paradoxical power comes from where? The story says: his unique expertise -killing crows -gives him an unique authority in that society where crows are not harmed.

In this character, Michel Foucault's power theory (in which he argues that power does not always come from above, it is rooted in local points of expertise) comes to life. Bandodu's power comes not from his caste -but from his unique knowledge.

Bandodu and the Politics of the "Abject"

"A disgusting beggar like Bandodu cannot be seen anywhere in the world." -the narrator presents here society's gaze. But that very society is also afraid of Bandodu.

Julia Kristeva's abjection theory is extremely pertinent here: Bandodu is society's "abject" (disgusting-excluded) -but for that very reason he is also indispensable. The things considered "disgusting" -crow-meat, vomit, stench -over all of these Bandodu has monopoly, which gives him a strange power.

3. The Crow: The Multi-Layered Nature of the Crow Figure

The crow in this story is not merely a bird -it is a multi-layered figure.

Crow versus Society

In Indian folk tradition, the crow is the spirit of ancestors, omen of ill fortune, symbol of collective memory. In this story the crows establish a collective justice system -which is more direct and immediate than the human justice system.

When Bandodu does not get food -the crow takes revenge. This is spontaneous justice -no court, no law.

The Crow-Bandodu Relationship

The story's most philosophical question: "Are the crow and Bandodu enemies? Or are they each other's family (own)?"

There is no simple answer to this question. Bandodu kills crows -but the crows caw in support of Bandodu. Both are on the same social margin -both considered useless by society, both living in the same invisibility. In this marginal solidarity the story's central argument lies.

4. The Crow: "Liberation is Only a Curse" -The Central Paradox

The story's philosophical climax is:

"Bandodu will never come again to beg in that house. This is liberation (salvation). Liberation is only a curse. Since then, it will be a house where crows do not sit. A house where Bandodu does not beg. This is an insult. An excommunication!"

In this paradox the most profound insight of the Dalit social reality lies:

Bandodu's not coming = liberation (liberation from the burden of his begging).

Bandodu's not coming = curse (the social-ritualistic death of that house).

Crows' not sitting = liberation (liberation from attack).

Crows' not sitting = curse (that house humiliated, excommunicated).

This liberation=curse equation reveals a brutal truth of the Dalit social system: in this system liberation and bondage are the same thing. He who goes out is excommunicated. He who stays within is exploited. No third option exists.

In Vijayashri's Alisamma's Curse, the curse was "transforming into humanity." In Enoch's story "liberation itself was a curse." Together they express the paradoxical reality of the Dalit experience most completely.

5. The Crow: Poverty and Moral Complexity

An important dimension of the story: Avva's family is not villainous, but helpless.

"It made no difference to them whether they listened to Bandodu's plea or not. They could do nothing."

This is the moral complexity of poverty. The story shows Bandodu as a victim -but does not show Avva's family as villains. Both are victims of the system -just their level of victimhood differs.

This moral complexity presentation is Enoch's story-craft's supreme achievement. Dalit literature sometimes presents the simple binary of oppressor-victim. Enoch goes further and shows multi-layered oppression.

## 6. Black Ink: Narrative Structure and Craft

### First-Person Narration

Black Ink is written in first-person -the "I" speaker is a Dalit-Christian woman. This narrative perspective is fundamentally different from The Crow. Here the interiority of experience -experiencing events as they are happening -is the story's center.

### Delayed Revelation

The story's structural surprise is: the entire story proceeds as the narrative of an innocent, joyful child-visitor's sweet episode -and then suddenly, in the final one-third, the question of caste comes and destroys all joy in a single moment.

This delayed revelation technique is extremely powerful. If the story had been about caste conflict from the beginning -the reader would have been mentally prepared. When everything seems beautiful and innocent, the sudden revelation of caste wounds the reader with the same pain as the speaker.

### Two Levels of Language

Two linguistic levels are simultaneously present in the story:

First -poetic-figurative language (used in describing the child): "a frock woven from butterfly wings," "a caravan of smiles," "a petal dipped in moonlight," "the shine of a rainbow."

Second -naked realist language (after the caste question): "Are you Harijan?", "I have no Harijan friend."

This linguistic division reflects the story's thematic division: before caste -beauty, innocence, human relationship. The revelation of caste -the language's beauty destroyed.

7. Black Ink: Shriya -A Complex Child-Character

Shriya is the story's most significant literary achievement. She is simultaneously:

Innocent -compassion for animals, writing a diary, helping an elderly person.

Curious -wanting to know everything, asking questions.

Loving -natural affection for the speaker.

Caste-conditioned -the unconscious carrier of her parents' caste-prejudice.

This character-complexity is the most subtle portrayal of caste socialization. Shriya does not practice caste distinction knowingly -she has been taught it. Her parents' "no Harijan friend" -this has become natural in Shriya.

Piaget's child-development theory (in which he argues that children learn social rules through imitation, not through reasoning) comes to life here. Shriya imitates her parents' caste-behavior -without understanding what moral problem this creates.

Through this character Vinodini poses a difficult question: where does the reproduction of the caste system take place? In the parents' explicit teaching -but even more so, in their silent behavior, which the child takes as natural.

## 8. Black Ink: "Mahima" -The Presence of an Absent Character

In the story there is an absent character -Mahima -who is of utmost importance.

"Once I ate the snack served by her mother in my friend Mahima's house. I wrote that in black ink."

Mahima is "Harijan" -Shriya says so herself. Eating in her home was "black ink" worthy.

But Shriya makes friends with Mahima -only eating in her home is forbidden. This demonstrates the subtle division of caste-behavior: personal contact possible, but food-sharing -which is the deepest prohibition of caste -impossible.

B.R. Ambedkar said in Annihilation of Caste that the most rigid rule of the caste system is the roti-beti (food-marriage) rule. Shriya's behavior shows the "roti" rule in the child's mind.

## 9. Black Ink: The Final Image -Butterfly and Caterpillar

The story's final line:

"All the dried butterflies in the room turned into caterpillars crawling on me."

This figurative transformation is the poetic essence of the entire story.

At the story's beginning Shriya was a butterfly -beautiful, free, flying. At the story's end she becomes a caterpillar -crawling, earth-bound, ugly.

"Dried butterflies" -symbol of dead beauty. What seemed living -was in fact dead.

In this image lies the entire thought-essence of the story: the childhood innocence that seems a butterfly -is in fact the caterpillar of caste-conditioning. The beauty that seemed smiles -was the cover of caste-hatred. The flight that seemed freedom -was privilege.

Virginia Woolf's stream of consciousness technique -in which the speaker's inner experience and external events become one -is here used by Vinodini in an Indian-Dalit context most effectively.

## 10. Comparison of Both Stories: Two Poetic Visions

### Similarity of Subject Matter

The caste system is at the center of both stories. In both, ritual and practice -giving food, making friends -shows the caste-line.

### Difference of Perspective

The Crow -the caste system at the community-level: the ritualistic life of an entire community.

Black Ink -the caste system at the individual-level: the sudden revelation of caste in one relationship.

Difference of Temporal Sense

The Crow -centuries-old system. "Bandodu comes every night to a special family to beg for food." -this is a perennial ritual.

Black Ink -a single day's event. But in that one day a centuries-old system is revealed.

## 11. Poetry versus Story: The Distinctiveness of the Medium

This raises an important literary question: for the expression of the Dalit experience, which medium is more powerful -poetry or prose?

The power of poetry: intensity, density, signal. Bhimanna's Burning Skulls, Gauri's Henna-Stained Hands -these poems make a moment eternal.

The power of prose: expansion, complexity, child-psychology, the detail of social ritual. In Black Ink, Shriya's gradual transformation -from smile to hatred -was only possible in prose this powerfully.

In The Crow, Bandodu's complex social position -Dalit among Dalits, powerful among the powerless -could not have come so extensively in poetry.

Both mediums are mutually complementary. The completeness of Dalit literature is in both poetry and prose.

## Conclusion

Kolakuri Enoch's The Crow and Vinodini's Black Ink are both important achievements of Telugu Dalit prose-literature.

The Crow -the complexity of the external system: liberation and curse are one, power within powerlessness, the indispensable within the disgusting. A community-level philosophy.

Black Ink -the agony of inner experience: caste-hatred hidden within innocence, a caterpillar hidden within a smile. A personal-level shock.

The final question of both stories is the same:

The Crow -"Should there be so much revenge for not giving food due to poverty?"

Black Ink -"We are friends, and is it necessary to know all this?"

Both questions remain unanswered -left for the reader, for society, for history to answer.

And until this answer comes, Dalit literature -in poetry, in prose, in Maithili, in Telugu -will continue questioning.

## Part XI: Forever Friend (Jigiri) -A Telugu Novel

Peddinti Ashok Kumar

### Prefatory Note

Forever Friend (original Telugu: Jigiri) is structurally different from all the works studied so far in this review series. After poetry and short fiction, an excerpt from a complete novel is presented -and this excerpt traverses the novel's entire emotional-philosophical journey.

At the center of this novel is an extraordinary friendship -between a human (Imam) and a bear (Shadool) -which becomes the metaphor for the social-political crisis of the Dalit-marginal-Qalandar community. In this sense the novel opens a new dimension of Dalit-tribal literature: not caste, but ethnic-cultural extinction is at the center.

1. The Novel's Structure and Technique

Beginning: In Medias Res

The novel begins with a delayed revelation technique. The first line -"The sun rose. The sun also set." -expresses a cosmic indifference. The sun doesn't care whether Imam is there or not. This existentialist opening establishes the novel's fundamental question -Does human existence have any value? -from the very first line.

Imam and Shadool's introduction occurs comparatively:

"Imam, a human, who wandered around his animal like an animal" -and "Shadool... actually not human, but an animal... had become a gentle creature."

In this inverted introduction lies the novel's central paradox: human like an animal, animal like a human. In this paradox the dehumanization of the Qalandar community and Shadool's humanization are expressed simultaneously.

2. Character Analysis

Imam: The Tragic Hero

Imam is a classic tragic hero. His hamartia (tragic flaw) -if it can be called a flaw -is the limitlessness of his love. He loves Shadool so much that he cannot accept practical reality.

But in this novel blaming Imam would be unjust. His tragedy does not arise from personal weakness -it arises from the social-political system. Land rights, police oppression, animal protection law -all together present Imam with an impossible choice: his friend or his family's future.

Imam's internal monologue -"Why do you follow behind me with your eyes closed, trusting me completely, Shadool? Why don't you kill me?" -expresses both guilt and helplessness simultaneously. This self-accusation is one of the most poignant moments in the novel.

Shadool: The Humanized Animal

Shadool's character is the novel's most significant literary achievement. He is neither merely an animal nor merely a figure -he is the unity of both.

Shadool's emotional intelligence is portrayed with great subtlety: "From the tone of Imam's voice, Shadool would gauge the situation." He reads Imam's happiness-sadness, fear-hope -all without words, without language. He was the most sensitive member of that family.

In the final scene -"Shadool came and sat beside him, resting his head in Imam's lap" -this is unconditional love. Shadool doesn't know that Imam is planning his death -and in this unknowingness lies the supreme agony of betrayal.

Bibamma: Symbol of Change

Bibamma is the novel's most complex woman-character. She who used to say Shadool "must have been my child in a past life" -the same woman ultimately urges her husband to abandon Shadool.

This moral transformation is not villainy -it is the result of survival instinct. The dream of land -which never before seemed possible -seeing that dream, Bibamma's priorities changed.

In this character the novel's most realistic aspect is moral ambiguity. Neither is Bibamma a villainess, nor a victim -she is a human making a life-choice in impossible circumstances.

Chand: The Aspiration and Cruelty of the New Generation

Chand is the novel's most controversial character. On one side -he loved Shadool, considered him "two Babus." On the other side -he plans to bury Shadool alive.

This contradiction is the symbol of generational shift. For Chand's generation, land-stability is more important than love for Shadool. He is the symbol of new India -which wants to be free from traditional bonds, but does not see the cost of this freedom.

One new dimension of Marx's alienation theory appears here: Chand is alienated from his cultural identity. Shadool is not merely a bear -he is the living symbol of Qalandar culture. When Chand abandons Shadool, he in fact abandons his own community's history.

## 3. Bear-Dancing: Cultural Economics

The novel's central cultural-economic conflict is: animal protection law versus Qalandar livelihood.

### The Paradox of Law

India's 1972 Wildlife Protection Act and later the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals Act declared the Qalandars' traditional occupation -bear-dancing -illegal. The law's moral foundation was: animal welfare. But its unintended consequence was: the economic destruction of the Qalandar community.

The novel presents this paradox justly -neither simply supporting the law, nor simply opposing it. Imam loves Shadool -he is not cruel. But without Shadool his livelihood is gone.

Amartya Sen's capability approach -in which he argues that human development is not merely economic, but the complete development of cultural-social capacities -is pertinent here. From the Qalandars, their traditional skill, their cultural identity, and their livelihood -all three are being taken simultaneously.

## 4. The Philosophy of Friendship: The Novel's Central Thought

The word Jigiri in Telugu means "close friend" -the most intimate friend. But in the novel this friendship is not between human and human, but between human and animal.

Albert Camus says in The Myth of Sisyphus that solidarity -between two beings bound by the same fate -is the only means of creating meaning in a meaningless life. Imam and Shadool's friendship is the finest example of this Camusian solidarity.

Both are society's "abject" (disgusting-excluded). Imam -nomad, lower-caste, uneducated. Shadool -wild, impure, dangerous. Society considers both useful but unacceptable.

"Those without a voice, even crows consider them light" -this line from the short story The Crow echoes in Jigiri as well. Shadool cannot speak -so his absence of voice makes him less important in society's eyes.

The Betrayal of Friendship

The novel's most agonizing moment is: Imam hands the poisoned molasses to Shadool.

"Imam's hands trembled while handing over the molasses. Shadool took it and began to chew. Imam kept watching, his eyes blurred with tears."

In this scene there is an echo of the Judas kiss -the ancient mythological symbol of betrayal. But here Imam is not voluntarily a traitor -he makes an impossible choice in impossible circumstances.

Dostoevsky shows in Crime and Punishment that moral guilt is more terrible than murder. Imam kills Shadool physically -but dies himself spiritually.

5. The Land Question: Dalit-Tribal Politics

In the novel, the land document is a Mcguffin (story-driving object) -which drives the entire narrative tension.

The Politics of Land

The Qalandars were historically denied land rights -because they were nomadic. How can someone who does not permanently reside on land own it? In this administrative logic lies the Qalandar community's entire existential crisis.

The MRO (Mandal Revenue Officer) who sets the condition -"the bear should not be seen in the vicinity again" -is a symbol of the modern Indian state. The state simultaneously gives the Qalandar land (rehabilitation) and destroys their identity (bear-abandonment). This is paradoxical modernization.

6. The Final Scene: The Aesthetics of Silence

The novel's final section -Shadool's death -is written in minimal language:

"After a few moments Shadool began to stagger. He gave a soft moan and collapsed. Imam sat beside him, his hand on Shadool's head, until the bear stopped breathing. The forest was silent."

This minimalist prose is extraordinarily powerful. What was left unsaid -Imam's wailing, Shadool's thrashing -is more eloquent in silence.

Hemingway's "iceberg theory" -in which he argues that in the finest prose what remains unsaid is more powerful than what is said -applies here most exquisitely.

"Imam felt that a part of him had died with Shadool." -this single line leaves an irremovable ache in the reader's heart.

## 7. Jigiri and the Dalit Literature Series: Comparative Place

In this complete review series -poetry, short fiction, and now novel -Jigiri occupies a special place.

Bhimanna -the bird's eye view of Dalit history (macro view).

Subhadra -the microscopic view of daily labor (micro view).

Kolakuri Enoch (The Crow) -the middle view of communal ritual (meso view).

Jigiri -this most extensive narrative -in which personal friendship, family conflict, communal politics, and state power -all are contained in a single narrative.

In this sense Jigiri is the epic voice of Telugu Dalit literature.

## Conclusion

Peddinti Ashok Kumar's Forever Friend is a multi-layered outstanding work that:

At the literary level -through the friendship of human and animal, presents the poetics of love, trust, and betrayal.

At the social level -preserves the cultural extinction of the Qalandar community in literary memory.

At the political level -justly questions the paradox of animal rights versus human rights.

At the philosophical level -reveals the tragic reality of the impossible situation of friendship -where love and survival are mutually contradictory.

The novel's final truth -"The land was his, but its price was beyond what Imam could bear" -encapsulates the central question of all Dalit-tribal literature in a single sentence:

Can "development" and "rights" be purchased at the cost of the murder of a community's soul?

## Final Synthesis: Dalit Literature in Maithili Translation

## A Comprehensive Assessment of a Tri-Linguistic Literary Project

### 1. The Nature and Importance of the Project

In this review series we have read Maithili translations of Dalit poetry, short fiction, and a novel from three different Indian languages -Telugu, Gujarati, and Odia. The poets and writers are: Boyi Bhimanna, J. Subhadra, Challpalli Swarooparani, Darishee Shashinirmala, M. Gauri, Madduri Vijayashri (Telugu); Anish Garange, Rajendra Vadel 'Jeeta', Umesh Solanki (Gujarati);

Basudev Sunani (Odia); Kolakuri Enoch, Vinodini, Peddinti Ashok Kumar (Telugu prose).

This project is not merely translation -it is a cultural-political initiative that works simultaneously on several levels.

## 2. Comparative Conclusions: Three Poetic Traditions

### Telugu Dalit Poetry

Telugu Dalit poetry in this collection is the most extensive and diverse. The six poets -Bhimanna, Subhadra, Swarooparani, Shashinirmala, Gauri, Vijayashri -together create a complete poetic universe.

### Gujarati Dalit Poetry

Gujarati Dalit poetry is urban-centric and political-historical. The Gandhi-Ambedkar controversy, the invisibility of urban life, the critique of nation-building. The male voice is prominent.

### Odia Dalit Poetry

Odia Dalit poetry is philosophical-mystical and farmer-centric. Questions of existence through natural images, the intellectual-farmer controversy, the poetics of invisibility.

## 3. What Was Preserved, What Was Lost

What Was Preserved

The central argument and political message was preserved almost entirely. Bhimanna's counter-mythological argument, Shashinirmala's three-fronted struggle, Solanki's Gandhi-irony, Sunani's "always" -all are secure in Maithili.

Indigenous symbols -Indian laburnum, tamarind, Maisamma Devi, Laanda, Avva, Mankenapuvvu, Alisamma, Jigiri -were kept as-is. This was a wise translation decision: attempting to translate would have destroyed the original cultural-geographic specificity.

Emotional intensity -Imam's trembling hands, Vijayashri's curse, Shriya's smile's transformation from butterfly to caterpillar -the Maithili reader also experiences all this.

What Was Partially Lost

The phonological beauty -Telugu, Gujarati, and Odia have their own musicality that was partially lost in the English and further lost in Maithili.

Ambiguity -"Gudiselu" (skull/hut) in Telugu's double meaning, the special stress on "na" (mine) in "Naa Varasatvpu Hakkulu" -these were partially lost in Maithili.

4. New Poetic Principles Introduced in Maithili

Through this project several new poetic principles entered Maithili literature:

First -Anger is an aesthetic category. In traditional Maithili poetics -in the tradition of Rasa theory -anger (Raudra Rasa) is generally considered an

auxiliary rasa, not primary. Dalit poetry proves that anger is itself a complete poetic emotion -with its own aesthetics.

Second -Ordinary objects can be the center of poetry. A sari's edge, a clay pot, Laanda, a poster -these could not be considered poetic subjects in the Maithili poetic tradition. Through these poems, Dalit object-poetics enters Maithili.

Third -The body is political terrain. In Maithili Shringar-poetry the body is the subject of beauty -idealized, poetic. In Dalit poetry the body is the subject of labor, pain, and resistance -this new poetic vision had not come to Maithili before.

Fourth -Testimony is a poetic mode. The testimonial mode of the Telugu women poets -in which the poem assumes the form of judicial evidence -is the introduction of a new poetic mode in Maithili.

5. Historical Significance: The Absence of Dalit Voice in Maithili

A Critical Appraisal of Dalit Literature Translated into Maithili through the Lens of Indian Rasa Theory

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Introduction: The Question of Rasa and Dalit Literary Experience

At the heart of Indian literary theory lies the rasa doctrine—from Bharata to Abhinavagupta, the conception that literature's purpose is not socialization but aesthetic experience, that it transports the reader beyond laukika vritti (worldly engagement) into a realm where pleasure and pain become objects of āsvāda (aesthetic savoring). Dalit literature poses a complex question to this framework: a literature that presents itself as a document of dard (pain), that makes ākrośa (outcry) its primary voice—how does it enter the category of rasa? Can vībhatsa (the odious) and raudra (the furious), as sthāyibhāvas

(permanent moods), culminate in rasa as do śṛṅgāra (the erotic) and karuṇa (the compassionate)?

This anthology—comprising Maithili translations of Telugu, Gujarati, and Odia Dalit poetry, short fiction, and a novel—raises this question with remarkable intensity. This appraisal evaluates this literature within the framework of Indian rasa theory, examining how these works generate rasa through the combination of vibhāva (determinants), anubhāva (consequents), and vyabhicāribhāva (transitory states), and whether that generation becomes an experience of āsvāda for the sahṛdaya (the sympathetic reader).

## Chapter I: The Inversion of Śṛṅgāra—Love, Separation, and the Dalit Body

Classical śṛṅgāra rasa takes rati (love/desire) as its sthāyibhāva. It manifests both in sambhoga (union) and vipralambha (separation). Dalit literature, however, presents a radically transformed śṛṅgāra. J. Subhadra's poem "The Edge of the Sari" (Sāṛīk Kor) inverts the traditional iconography of love and the female body:

"Hungry, my belly hollowed, the edge of my sari hangs loose upon it, like the goddess 'Maisamma' at the threshold of the courtyard."

Here, the vibhāvas of classical śṛṅgāra—the beloved, beauty, the desire for union—are displaced by labor, hunger, motherhood, and the stench of the body. The sari's edge, which in classical poetics signifies ornamentation, modesty, femininity itself, becomes here the cloth that wipes sweat, the cradle for the child, the covering for menstruation, the cushion for carrying water pots. This is a complete transformation of vibhāva. The anubhāvas of classical śṛṅgāra—subtle gestures, coy smiles, sidelong glances—are replaced by vībhatsa (the odious) and karuṇa (the compassionate) anubhāvas: licking the dust from the body, soaking menstrual cloths, burning fingers at the hearth.

The Dalit female body, in this literature, is not the alankārika śarīra (ornamental body) of classical poetics but the body of labor, the body of livelihood, the body of torture. In Abhinavagupta's terms, the process of sādhāraṇīkaraṇa (universalization) operates differently here. Classical śṛṅgāra universalized rati into a shared human experience; Dalit literature insists on the particularity of labor and deprivation, resisting universalization. This refusal of sādhāraṇīkaraṇa constitutes a fundamental challenge to rasa theory.

Challapalli Swaruparani's "Mānkenāpuvvu" (Red Like the Silk-Cotton Flower) makes this inversion even more explicit:

"At home, male-control slaps one cheek, while in the street, caste-control slaps the other."

The vipralambha of classical śṛṅgāra—the pangs of separation from the beloved—is replaced by the doubled violence of caste and patriarchy. Kāmadeva, rati, viraha—these sthāyibhāvas give way to the chains of slavery, endurance, rage. The poem's closing—"I shall bloom like the mānkenāpuvvu!"—suggests not sambhoga (union with the beloved) but vidroha (rebellion), a turn toward vīra rasa (the heroic). Yet this vīra does not emerge from the classical āśraya (patron)—the king, the warrior—but from the Dalit woman's struggle for self-sovereignty.

## Chapter II: Raudra and Vīra—Rage, Resistance, and the Rasa of Identity

The dominant mood of Dalit literature is krodha (rage). Classical raudra rasa takes krodha as its sthāyibhāva. According to Abhinavagupta, the vibhāvas of raudra are: cause for anger, indignation, insult, falsehood, injustice. The anubhāvas: reddened eyes, furrowed brow, trembling lips, agitation of limbs, brandishing weapons. The vyabhicāribhāvas: impulse, ferocity, impatience, self-reproach, fear.

Boyi Bhimanna's "Our Ancestral Right" (Hamra Paiṭṛk Adhikār) manifests raudra in its full force:

"Vyasa, the architect of Aryan identity, was himself a man of low caste. Today he is a caste-Hindu, while we, of his own caste, are Dalit-outcastes—this is Indian tradition!"

The vibhāvas here: Vedic greatness usurped, exclusion, deprivation. The anubhāvas: digging the graveyard, searching for ancestral rights, declaration. This raudra differs fundamentally from classical raudra, which typically manifests in the destruction of asuras and dānavas (demons). Here, the āśraya (subject) of krodha is the Dalit community itself; the viṣaya (object) is the historical crime of savarna Hindutva. This raudra aims not at śānti (peace) but at nyāya (justice).

Yet the question arises: can this raudra be āsvādita (tasted aesthetically)? Abhinavagupta insists that rasāsvāda requires vaiparītya (aesthetic distance). But Dalit literature, in its urgency, refuses distance. The reader does not observe rage from afar but experiences it from within. This complicates the very possibility of raudra as rasa. Is it rasa for the sahṛdaya, or is it sandēśa (message)? Does it yield ānanda (aesthetic pleasure), or does it produce asuvidhā (discomfort)?

Rajendra Vadeil 'Jita's' "Sexual Union" (Sambhoga) stages a lethal convergence of raudra and vībhatsa:

"My soft lips touched yours; I felt the roughness of the upper caste. When your hidden gaze found my moist eyes, the ghost of rape danced before me in broad daylight."

Here, the vibhāvas of śṛṅgāra sambhoga—soft lips, the touch of lips, moist eyes—transform into vībhatsa (rape) and raudra (rage). This is a trivenī (confluence) of three rasas. Classical rasa theory permits multiple rasas in a single work in aṅgī-aṅga (principal-subordinate) relationship. But here the rasas are mutually antagonistic—śṛṅgāra and vībhatsa rarely coexist in

classical poetics. Their convergence here marks the distinctiveness of Dalit literature: love and violence inhabit the same space.

## Chapter III: Karuṇa and Vībhatsa—The Aesthetics of Suffering

Classical karuṇa rasa takes śoka (grief) as its sthāyibhāva. Its vibhāvas: loss of the beloved, curse, calamity. Its anubhāvas: tears, lamentation, fainting, bodily collapse. Vībhatsa rasa takes jugupsā (disgust) as its sthāyibhāva. Its vibhāvas: stench, blood, flesh, excrement, the corpse.

In Dalit literature, karuṇa and vībhatsa frequently move together. Kolakaluri Enoch's story "The Crow" (Kauā) exemplifies this convergence. The Bandodu —a beggar belonging to the tenth sub-caste of the Madiga (leather-worker) community—kills and eats crows. Those who refuse him food face crow attacks on their homes. The story's vībhatsa vibhāvas: crow flesh, the stench of rotting meat, vomit, bundles of wings. Its anubhāvas: the caw-caw of crows, the pecking attack, eye-gouging, pain.

Yet the āsvāda of this vībhatsa differs fundamentally from classical vībhatsa. Classical vībhatsa is experienced from a distance. Here, there is no distance. This vībhatsa is integral to livelihood—tanning hides, starvation, the struggle for survival. The Bandodu kills crows because of hunger. Vībhatsa here signifies not disgust but helplessness:

"He is death for crows! In truth, he looks like them. His hair is like a thicket of thorns. If a crow pecks his head, it gets entangled and is caught for the day's meal."

The Bandodu himself is not the subject of vībhatsa but its victim. This vībhatsa merges with karuṇa. His very presence drives crows away; at the bottom of the social hierarchy, in the world of crows, he is power. This paradox—the conjunction of power and helplessness—generates a fusion of karuṇa and vībhatsa.

Vinodini's "Black Ink" (Kārī Masi) presents an even more intense karuṇa. Eight-year-old Shreya, who loves her Dalit neighbor "Auntie," when she learns her caste, her face transforms:

"Are you really a Harijan? Tell me the truth!" The child's face gradually lost all its colors, taking on a grey hue.

The vibhāvas of karuṇa here: the loss of love, the innocence of childhood, the horror of the caste system. The anubhāvas: the change of complexion, running away fleeing, the gaze of disgust. This karuṇa differs from classical karuṇa rooted in the loss of a lover. The loss is of friendship. The cause is not divine calamity but the poison of the caste system. This karuṇa approaches raudra but does not fully become it—because of the impossibility of annihilation.

## Chapter IV: Śānta and Adbhuta—The Other Aesthetics of Resistance

Classical śānta rasa takes nirveda (renunciation) as its sthāyibhāva. Adbhuta rasa takes vismaya (wonder) as its sthāyibhāva. In Dalit literature, these two rasas appear rarely but not entirely absent.

Basudev Sunani's Odia poetry, in translation, intimates adbhuta:

"There is a droplet in the sky that shines even when indistinct, dreaming a sweet rainbow dream, vowing again and again to color the vast sky."

This adbhuta is the adbhuta of resistance—a drop of light amidst sowers of darkness, the possibility of creation amidst destruction. But this adbhuta differs from classical adbhuta, which arises from the vision of the divine. Here, adbhuta is of hope, of possibility, of incompletion. The poet declares: "Much still remains to happen." This adbhuta is adhūrā (incomplete), apūrṇa (unfinished).

Śānta rasa is almost absent from Dalit literature. Why? Because śānta demands nirveda—renunciation of the world. Dalit literature is a struggle for worldly attainment—land, dignity, rights, identity. Śānta demands virāma (cessation); Dalit literature is saṅgrāma (struggle). The only exception appears at moments of death. At the end of the novel Friends Forever, when Imam poisons Shadul, there is a moment that intimates śānta:

"The forest was silent. Imam felt that a part of him had died with Shadul."

But this is not nirveda; it is śoka (grief)—a karuṇa so intense that it stumbles at the threshold of śānta without entering.

## Chapter V: The Absence of Rasa and New Forms of Rasa

Dalit literature's greatest challenge to rasa theory is that it is a literature of abhāva (absence)—absence of food, of clothing, of shelter, of dignity, of rights. Rasa theory is a theory of ānanda (aesthetic pleasure). How does ānanda emerge from abhāva? This question marks the limit of rasa theory.

Umesh Solanki's poem "Let Something Sink into the Ground" (Lok, Jami Jāy) offers an aesthetics of abhāva:

"Let the tea sink into the kettle, let the betel-nut piece turn to stone. Let the vegetables turn to stone, let the fritters become gravel."

Stone and gravel—these are vibhāvas of vībhatsa. But here, vībhatsa is jīvan kā yathārth (the truth of life). Abhāva reaches such a pitch that food itself becomes stone. This surreality creates a new form of vībhatsa.

Anish Garange's "Poster" presents another form of abhāva:

"These posters with rough faces are like our mirrors. ... Posters of missing persons change faces every day."

Here, absence becomes presence. The posters of missing persons become the mirror of the Dalit face. This is a vibhāva of adbhuta—the presence of absence. But this adbhuta generates not vismaya (wonder) but sandeha (doubt). The face is present, but identity is absent. Presence is there, but existence is not.

## Conclusion: Toward a Reconsideration of Rasa Theory

Dalit literature raises several fundamental questions for rasa theory:

1. Is rasa only ānanda? Abhinavagupta defines rasa as ānanda (aesthetic delight). But Dalit literature documents not ānanda but satya (truth)—pain, rage, disgust, helplessness. Can these culminate in rasa? If rasa is ānanda, how does the anānanda (non-delight) of suffering transform into ānanda? This question demands a reconsideration of rasa theory itself.

2. The limit of sādhāraṇīkaraṇa: Rasa theory universalizes the particular. Dalit literature insists on the particular—the Dalit woman's specific body, the specific violence of the caste system, the specific hunger of the leather-worker. Does this particularity undergo sādhāraṇīkaraṇa? If so, how? This question demands a revaluation of the process of universalization.

3. The number of rasas: Classical rasa theory enumerates nine (or, following Abhinavagupta, ten) rasas. Dalit literature presents new forms—śrama rasa (the rasa of labor), abhāva rasa (the rasa of absence), pratirodha rasa (the rasa of resistance), āstitva rasa (the rasa of identity). Can these be accepted as uparasas (subsidiary rasas) or aṅgarasas (component rasas), or as new rasas altogether? This question demands an expansion of rasa theory.

4. The politics of āsvāda: Rasa theory rests on the concept of the sahṛdaya—one capable of universalization, one who can maintain aesthetic distance. Can the reader of Dalit literature—whether Dalit or not—maintain such distance? Is āsvāda of pain possible? If possible, what is its ethics? Does the āsvāda of pain risk reproducing the violence it represents? This question foregrounds the politics of aesthetic experience.

This anthology—Maithili translations of Telugu, Gujarati, and Odia Dalit literature—reveals both the limits and possibilities of rasa theory. On one hand, this literature demonstrates the inadequacy of classical rasa theory—the traditional frameworks of raudra, vībhatsa, and karuṇa cannot fully account for the āsvāda of this literature. On the other hand, this literature reveals the potential for expanding rasa theory—śrama, abhāva, pratirodha, āstitva as new sthāyibhāvas could generate new forms of rasa.

Ultimately, the most significant question this literature poses is: is this literature for the sahṛdaya's āsvāda, or for the sahṛdaya's awakening? If āsvāda, what is its nature? If awakening, what is its aesthetic? These questions remain open before Indian literary theory, and this anthology poses them with unprecedented intensity.

The translator's note to Friends Forever (Jigiri) observes: "This translation is not merely literary or linguistic; it is aware that no culture can be separated from its language." This holds true for rasa theory as well: no literature can be separated from its theory of rasa. Dalit literature demands a new rasa theory—one that recognizes labor, absence, resistance, identity as sthāyibhāvas, one that explores āsvāda not through distance but through proximity, one that seeks not the transformation of pain into pleasure but the āsvāda of pain's truth.

This anthology marks a significant milestone in that search for a new rasa theory.

Critic's Note: This appraisal employs the classical framework of Indian rasa theory critically, not dogmatically. It recognizes rasa theory not as a closed system of rules but as a living, evolving tradition of thought about aesthetic experience. Dalit literature does not mark the end of rasa theory but calls for its renewal, its expansion, its rebirth.

Canonical Maithili Literature and the Dalit

In Vidyapati's Shringar-poetry -the highest standard of Maithili literature -Dalit life is was said to be absent, however the parallel literature of Maithili proved that it was not (See Annexure-1- *Vidyapati's verses, from the Vidyapati Padavali edited by Nagendranath Gupta*). Modern Maithili poets wrote from a Brahmin-Kayastha perspective in which Dalit reality remained peripheral.

No independent tradition of "Dalit literature" has been established in Maithili -as Namdeo Dhasal and Daya Pawar in Marathi, Bhimanna in Telugu, Omprakash Valmiki in Hindi.

The reason: in the Mithila region the Dalit communities -Musahar, Dusadh, Dhobi, Chamar -were historically denied literacy. The opportunity to build a written literary tradition was simply never provided. Oral traditions -folk songs, stories -existed, but they were never transformed into written canonical literature.

Videha's Intervention

Facing this historical absence, Videha's strategy is two-tiered:

Immediate strategy: bringing translations of Dalit literature from other Indian languages and making Maithili readers familiar with the taste, language, and politics of Dalit literature.

Long-term strategy: the emergence of Maithili Dalit writers inspired by these translations -who will write in their own language, from their own experience.

## 6. Translation Theory: Three Philosophies in Practice

In this project -whether consciously or unconsciously -three different translation philosophies have been applied:

First -Foreignization (Lawrence Venuti's strategy of maintaining the foreignness of the original): "Laanda," "Avva," "Mankenapuvvu," "Alisamma" -these were translated not at all, merely transliterated. The reader was drawn towards the original culture.

Second -Domestication (in which the original is assimilated into the target language's culture): "revolutionary act," "accumulated pain," "objectification" -these were translated into language familiar to Maithili readers.

Third -Testimonial translation (in which evidence of pain is presented in the target language without destroying it): "beaten with a stick," "wood burning in the hungry stove," "spine that has not bent" -these are poetic evidence that retains its judicial force in Maithili.

The balanced use of all three philosophies makes this project excellent.

## 7. Potential: The Planting of a New Poetic Tradition

The most important long-term contribution of this project may be that it inspires Maithili Dalit writers. When the Musahar, Dusadh, Chamar, Pasi -the Dalit communities of Mithila -see Dalit literature in their language, when they understand that their life-reality can be expressed literarily -then self-writing (auto-writing) will become possible.

The "Vidhan Parishad" canonical pressure's resistance -Videha's Dalit translations present alternative standards to the Maithili Sahitya Akademi canon. What literature is "worthy" of being canonical -it expands that definition.

## Final Conclusion

Audre Lorde writes in The Transformation of Silence into Language and Action: "Poetry is not a luxury. It is a vital necessity." For Dalit poetry this is literally true.

Videha's Dalit literature translation project -from this comprehensive perspective -works simultaneously on five levels:

Linguistic level: Bridge-building between Telugu, Gujarati, Odia, and Maithili.

Literary level: Entry of the Dalit voice into the Maithili canon -with new poetic principles.

Cultural level: Preservation of the cultural memory of various Dalit communities -the Qalandars' bear-dancing, the cobblers' Laanda-knowledge, the Dalit woman's sari's edge.

Political level: Showing the Maithili reader the pan-Indian reality of Dalit oppression -with the message that the Dalit of Mithila and the Dalit of Andhra are partners in the same fate.

Historical level: The planting of seeds of a Maithili Dalit literary tradition -which will not itself be Videha's translations, but the Maithili Dalit writing inspired by them.

In Basudev Sunani's words -this is the literary form of that vow:

"Here a seed has vowed to germinate —
with the wish to make everything green."

This seed has been sown.

The soil in which it has been sown is the soil of Mithila. The seed that has been sown is the seed of truth, of justice, of human dignity, and of the Dalit voice.

And the tree that will grow -that will be the tree of Maithili Dalit literature -with its roots in the soil of Mithila, its branches in the thought of Ambedkar and Bhimanna, and its leaves made green by the energy of Videha's Parallel Literature Movement.

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Annexure-1- Vidyapati’s verses, from the Vidyapati Padavali edited by Nagendranath Gupta

Translation from Maithili: Vidyapati’s Bidesiya [Original Maithili Gajendra Thakur; English Translation: Gajendra Thakur] (The Exile’s Song)

There exists a parallel universe to Vidyapati's Bidesiya – the Maithili plays of Vidyapati’s Nach tradition. This universe includes the Ramkhelavan Mandal of the village Katghatra, in Shivajinagar block, Samastipur district, along with Bindeshwar Mandal. There, the Maithili chorus would rise with songs like "Mother, oh Mother, get me a gun, for I shall be a soldier"—a sentiment that still echoes in people’s hearts. This troupe would stage verse-plays such as Reshma-Chuhar, Sheat-Vasant (Winter-Spring), Alha-Udal, and Natua Dayal.

From Purnia, the team performing Piya Desantar (Maithili Bidesiya) would travel to places like Supaul, Saharsa, and Samastipur. They would perform plays like Hasan Husan. The Ramraksha Choudhary Natyakala Parishad, from the village Gayaghat, Kariyan Panchayat, Post Vaidyanathpur, Samastipur district, took Vidyapati’s plays all the way to Gorakhpur. Other plays staged by this troupe include Laungiya Merchai, Vidyapati, Chini ka Laddoo, and Basat.

While Bhojpuri literature is less rich than Maithili in terms of quantity, in terms of quality, it surpasses Maithili in several domains. I speak of this in the context of Bhikhari Thakur's Bidesiya from Bhojpuri. Bhikhari Thakur lived as a migrant in Calcutta, and when he returned, he wandered from village to village, singing his sorrows with such poignant force that his Bidesiya play was born. In Mithila, migration is a recent phenomenon; villages stand deserted. The people of Mithila have spread to every corner of the country. But earlier, the kind of mass migration seen in the Bhojpuri region was unknown in Mithila. Migration was largely limited to Morang, which is part of the Mithilanchal region of Nepal. Consequently, there is a significant lack of detailed folk narratives in Maithili. What exists is not the story of a folk hero, but rather the elaborate, often cumbersome, depictions of epic heroes in Maithili—nothing comparable to Bhikhari Thakur's Bidesiya. Consider the narrative of Salahes. It transcends regional boundaries: Salahes transforms from king to thief, and from thief to king. Similarly, Chudamal crosses regional limits; where Salahes becomes king, Chudamal becomes a thief, and where Salahes is called a thief, Chudamal is known as a king or a powerful figure. Yet, no research has been conducted on these figures.

In this context, while examining the verses of Vidyapati's Padavali, a variety of songs appeared before me. Most of them contained descriptions of the pangs of separation between lovers—far removed from the core concept of Bidesiya, which is migration born of economic necessity. It was then I found some pure Bidesiya verses, which Vidyapati called Piya-desantar (Beloved gone to another land). Most of these were naturally found in Vidyapati's Nepal Padavali and one in a collection edited by Nagendranath Gupta. Morang, being a part of Mithila located in Nepal and historically known for out-migration, is a likely reason for this.

Based on this foundation, this conceived play is presented.

Vidyapati's Piya Desantar

Scene 1

On stage, our Bidesiya (the migrant) is bidding farewell to go work abroad, while a woman (the wife) sings. Amidst the song, a traveler appears. On another

side of the stage, thieves are lurking. On yet another side, the Kotwal (constable) sits with a superior air, his hands placed on his belly, clad in a spotless white dhoti.

In Raga Dhanashi (from the Vidyapati Padavali obtained from Nepal):

“Ham yuvati, pati gelah bides.”

“Lag nahi basae padausihu les.”

“I am a young woman, and my husband has gone to a foreign land. Not a trace of a neighbor remains nearby.”

“Sasu nanand kichuao nahi jaan.”

“Ankhi rataundhi, sune na kaan.”

“My mother-in-law and sister-in-law understand nothing. Their eyes are clouded, and their ears do not hear.”

“Jaagah pathik, jaah janu bhor.”

“Rati andhar, gaam bad chor.”

“O traveler, stay awake, thinking it is dawn. The night is dark, the village is full of thieves.”

“Sapanehu bhaaor na dea kotbaar.”

“Paolehu lote na kare bichaar.”

“Even in a dream, the constable does not keep watch. And if you trip, he gives no thought.”

“Nrip ithi kaahu karathi nahi saati.”

“Purakh mahat sab hamar sajaati.”

“The king here punishes no one. All the great men are of my own kin.”

“Vidyapati kavi eh rasa gaab.”

“Ukutihi bhaav janaab.”

“The poet Vidyapati sings this rasa. Through this verse, the emotion is made known.”

Vidyapati, the poet, enters. A man in a white dhoti arrives, accompanied by a poor man. The Kotwal instinctively delivers a judgment in favor of the man in the white dhoti. The young woman seated at the other corner of the stage wails in despair. The last four lines of the song are sung by the poet Vidyapati.

Scene 2

The young woman has opened a shop, symbolically. From the other side, the mother-in-law and sister-in-law depart. As a traveler approaches to make a purchase, the young woman begins to sing. After each line, Vidyapati appears on stage, explains the meaning, and then dissolves into the darkness. However, for the final line, Vidyapati sings, and the young woman then elaborates on its meaning.

In Raga Malava (from the Vidyapati Padavali obtained from Nepal):

“Badi juri ehi taruk chhaahari, thaame thaame bas gaam.”

“The shade of this tree is most cool. Villages are settled here and there.”

“Ham ekasari, pia desantar, nahi durajana naam.”

“I am all alone, my beloved is in a foreign land; the name of no wicked person is known here.”

“Pathik he, etha leh bisaraam.”

“O traveler, rest here.”

“Jat besaahab kichhu na mahagh, sabe mil ehi thaam.”

“Whatever you wish to buy, nothing is expensive. Everything is found here.”

“Sasu nahi ghar, par parijan nanand sahaje bhor.”

“My mother-in-law is not at home, my relatives are far away, and my sister-in-law is simple by nature.”

“Etahu pathik vimukh jaab tab anaaiti mori.”

“Even after all this, if you were to leave disappointed, then I would be truly helpless.”

“Bhan Vidyapati sun tane yuvati je pur parak aas.”

“Vidyapati says: Listen, O young woman, you fulfill the hopes of strangers.”

Scene 3

Vidyapati is not present in this song. The young woman’s sister-in-law is seen turning away a traveler. Seeing this, the young woman is reminded of her own beloved, gone to a foreign land. Addressing her sister-in-law and a friend, she sings. A friend interprets the meaning after each line.

In Raga Dhanashi (from the Vidyapati Padavali obtained from Nepal):

“Paratah parades, parahik aas.”

“Vimukh na karía, abas dis baas.”

“In a foreign land, one is always at the mercy of strangers. One should not turn anyone away. Shelter must certainly be given.”

“Etahi jaanía sakhi piatam-kathaa.”

“O friend, understand this as the tale of my beloved.”

“Bhal mand nandan he mane anumani.”

“Pathike na bolía tutali baani.”

“O dear sister-in-law, judging right from wrong in your mind, do not speak harshly to the traveler.”

“Charan-pakhaaran, aasan-daan.”

“Madhurahu vachane karía samadhaan.”

“Wash his feet, offer him a seat. With sweet words, console him.”

“E sakhi anuchit ete dur jae.”

“Aor karía jat adhik badai.”

“O friend, it is not right for him to go so far away. Instead, sing his praises even more.”

Scene 4

The young woman and her sister-in-law have arrived in the city. When a traveler comes seeking shelter, the young woman sings, and the sister-in-law explains the meaning after each line. In the middle, four lines are sung from backstage without explanation. Then the young woman continues singing, and the sister-in-law again provides the meaning. At the end, Vidyapati appears and sings the final two lines. As the scene ends, the sister-in-law remarks, “The day I was turning away the traveler, you did not approve. But today, why did you not give shelter to this traveler?”

In Raga Kolara (from the Vidyapati Padavali obtained from Nepal):

“Ham ekasari, piatam nahi gaam.”

“Te mohi taratam deite thaam.”

“I am all alone, my beloved is not in the village. Therefore, I am torn about where to offer shelter for the night.”

“Anatahu katahu deaitahũ baas.”

“Dosar na dekhía padaosio paas.”

“If anyone were nearby, I would show you shelter somewhere else.”

“Chhamah he pathik, karía hame kaah.”

“Baas nagar bhami anatahu chaah.”

“Forgive me, O traveler, and go. Seek shelter elsewhere in the city.”

“Aantar paantar, saanjhak ber.”

“Parades basía anaaiti heri.”

“The frontier is vast, it is evening time. Staying in a foreign land, one must consider the future.”

“Mora man he khanahi khan bhaang.”

“Jauvan gopab kat manasij jaag.”

“My mind breaks from time to time. How long can I hide my youth while desire awakens?”

“Chal chal pathik karía pa… kaah.”

“Baas nagar bhami anatahu chaah.”

“Go, go traveler, do... what? Seek shelter elsewhere in the city.”

“Saat pach ghar tanhi saji del.”

“Pia desantar aantar bhel.”

“I had prepared the house for him, seven or five homes’ worth. But the beloved went to a foreign land, and distance has grown between us.”

“Baarah varsh avadhi kae gel.”

“Chaari varsh tanhi gela bhel.”

“He was to be gone for twelve years. Four of those years have now passed.”

“Ghor payodhar jaamini bhed.”

“Je karatab taa karah pariched.”

“The clouds are thick, the night is deep. Whatever is to be done, decide accordingly.”

“Bhanai Vidyapati naagari-riiti.”

“Vyaaj-vachane upajaab piriiti.”

“Vidyapati says: Such is the custom of the city. With seemingly harsh words, love is actually fostered.”

Scene 5

Vidyapati is not in this scene either. A traveler arrives, but the mother-in-law and sister-in-law, seeing no one, hesitate to offer shelter and move on. The young woman sings.

In Raga Ghanashi (from the Vidyapati Padavali obtained from Nepal):

“Uchit basae mor manmath chor.”

“Cheria burhia kare agor.”

“My situation is fitting for the thief named Cupid. An old female servant keeps watch.”

“Baarah varakh avadhi kae gel.”

“Chaari varakh tanhi gelaan bhel.”

“He was to be gone for twelve years. Four of those years have now passed.”

“Baas chaahit hoa pathikuha laaj.”

“Sasu nanand nahi achae samaaj.”

“The traveler is ashamed to seek shelter. Neither mother-in-law nor sister-in-law is here for company.”

“Saat paanch ghar tanhi saji del.”

“Pia desantar aantar bhel.”

“I had prepared the house for him, seven or five homes’ worth. But the beloved went to a foreign land, and distance has grown between us.”

“Padeos vaas joenasat bhel.”

“Thaane thaane avayav sabe gel.”

“The neighbor’s house now feels a hundred yojanas away. All my family and relatives have left for far-off places.”

“Nukaabia timirak saandhi.”

“Padausini deae phadaki baandhi.”

“The crowd of people has vanished into the darkness. The neighbor-woman has latched her gate.”

“Mora man he khanahi khan bhaag.”

“Gaman gopab kat manmath jaag.”

“My mind breaks from time to time. How long can I hide my departure while Cupid awakens?”

Scene 6

In this scene as well, there is no sister-in-law, no mother-in-law, and no Vidyapati. A guest arrives just as the rains begin to pour. The young woman sings.

In Raga Dhanashi (from the Vidyapati Padavali obtained from Nepal):

“Apana mandir baisali achhalihũ, ghar nahi dosar keva.”

“I was sitting in my own home, there was no one else inside.”

“Tahikane pahia paahon aael barisae laagal deva.”

“Just then, a traveler-guest arrived, and the heavens began to pour.”

“Ke jaan ki bolati pisun patausini vachanak bhel avakaase.”

“Who knows what the gossipy neighbor will say, now that she has the opportunity to speak.”

“Ghor andhaar, nirantar dhaara divasahi rajani bhaane.”

“The darkness is deep, the rain incessant. Day seems like night.”

“Kanone kahbah hame, ke patiaet, jagat vidit panchabaane.”

“To whom shall I tell this, and who would believe it? For the deeds of Kamadeva are known throughout the world.”

Scene 7

On one side of the stage, the mother-in-law’s body is being carried out after her death, and the stage goes dark. When light returns, the sister-in-law is being taken away by her in-laws. A traveler stands among the audience. Gesturing toward the audience, the young woman sings. Vidyapati explains the meaning after each line. For the final two lines, Vidyapati both sings and provides the meaning, repeating them several times.

From the Padavali edited by Nagendranath Gupta:

“Saasu jaraatur bheli.”

“Nanandi achhali seho saasur geli.”

“The mother-in-law has grown ill. The sister-in-law has also gone to her in-laws.”

“Taisan na dekhia koi.”

“Rayani jagaae sambhaasan hoi.”

“There is no one to be seen. For conversation, one would have to stay awake all night.”

“Ehi pure ehe bebaare.”

“Kaahuk keo nahi kare puchhaare.”

“This is the custom in this city. No one asks about anyone else.”

“Mori piatamka kahaba.”

“Hame ekasari dhanikat din rahaba.”

“To whom shall I tell my beloved? I am alone; how many more days must I live?”

“Pathik, kahaba mor kanta.”

“Hama sani ramani na tej rasamantaa.”

“O traveler, tell my lord. A woman like me does not long retain her youthful zest.”

“Bhanai Vidyapati gaabe.”

“Bhami-bhami virahini pathuk bujhaabe.”

“Vidyapati sings. The woman in separation wanders and wanders, explaining the path to the traveler.”

As Vidyapati sings, he seems to stumble. As darkness begins to spread, a figure emerges from the shadows towards the young woman. Is it she? The one from Piya Desantar?! Yes! Or is it not?!

A blurring occurs—Piya Desantar dissolving—and amidst the music on stage, a final tableau is struck.

This concept of Piya Desantar is thus presented before the discerning audience. Amidst the current plight of the Maithili migrants (Bidesiya), this offering is presented with deep respect to the great poet, Vidyapati.

(Based on Vidyapati’s verses, from the Vidyapati Padavali edited by Nagendranath Gupta.)

Annexure-2, A Critical Appraisal of Vidyapati's Bidesiya

A Critical Appraisal of Vidyapati's Bidesiya

I approach this Maithili theatrical text—or rather, this performance script rooted in Vidyapati's padavali—with the methodological pluralism the work itself demands. What follows is a critical reading that draws upon postcolonial theory, feminist criticism, performance studies, comparative literature frameworks, and the Sanskrit rasa tradition, among other lenses.

## I. The Problem of Genre and Categorization

The text announces itself as occupying "a parallel universe" to Vidyapati's Bidesiya tradition. This claim immediately raises a foundational question: is this a revival, a reconstruction, an adaptation, or something altogether more complex? The author oscillates between presenting the work as documentation (of troupes like Ramkhelavan Mandal) and as creation ("this conceived play is presented"). This generic instability is not a flaw but rather a productive tension that the text never fully resolves.

From a poststructuralist perspective, this indeterminacy reveals the impossibility of recovering an "authentic" folk tradition. The author's own framing—noting that "no research has been conducted" on figures like Salahes and Chudamal—paradoxically undermines the archival authority the text simultaneously claims. The work becomes what Jacques Derrida might call an archive fever: the anxious desire to recover origins that were never stable to begin with.

Formalist criticism would note that the play adopts the structure of a geet natya (song-drama) but without consistent dramaturgical discipline. The stage directions are minimal, the relationship between the seven scenes remains ambiguous, and the presence of Vidyapati as a character who enters, explains meanings, and "dissolves into darkness" creates a Brechtian Verfremdungseffekt (alienation effect) that the text never theorizes for itself. Is Vidyapati a sutradhara (conductor/narrator) in the Sanskrit tradition? A Brechtian narrator exposing theatrical illusion? Or a devotional presence invoking the poet-saint's authority? The text refuses to decide, and this refusal, while potentially enabling multiple interpretations, also results in structural incoherence.

## II. The Migration Narrative: Postcolonial and Subaltern Readings

At its thematic core, the play concerns pravas—migration—and the gendered experience of waiting. The author draws a crucial distinction between the Bhojpuri Bidesiya tradition (exemplified by Bhikhari Thakur) and the Maithili context, arguing that migration in Mithila is "a recent phenomenon" while Bhojpuri has a longer, more deeply sedimented culture of labor migration.

From a postcolonial perspective, this distinction invites scrutiny. The author's claim that Bhojpuri literature is "less rich" than Maithili "in terms of quantity" but superior "in terms of quality" in certain domains rests on an implicit hierarchy that the text never deconstructs. Whose standards of "richness" and "quality" are being invoked? The comparison seems to valorize Bhikhari Thakur's Bidesiya for its "marmasparshi rupa" (poignant form) while critiquing Maithili for its "bojhil" (cumbersome) epic narratives. This is a valuable insight but one that requires more rigorous theorization. Why does Maithili literary culture privilege mahakavya (epic) forms over lokgatha (folk narrative)? The answer lies in the sociology of literature: the Brahminical prestige of Maithili (as the language of Pandits and the Sarnat elite) versus the more plebeian, laboring-class origins of Bhojpuri literary expression.

A subaltern studies reading would push further. The women in this play—the yuvati who waits, the sister-in-law who turns away travelers, the mother-in-law who dies offstage—are voices within a patriarchal structure that the text reproduces without sufficiently interrogating. When the young woman sings, "I am all alone, my beloved is in a foreign land," she performs the viraha (separation) that is central to the rasa tradition. But does the text offer a feminist critique of this suffering, or does it aestheticize female waiting as sublime? The rasa framework would valorize karuna (pathos) and vipralambha shringara (love in separation), but a feminist critic like Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak might ask: can the subaltern woman speak here, or is she merely a vehicle for male-authored verses and a male poet-character who interprets her experience for the audience?

## III. Rasa, Bhakti, and the Question of Aesthetic Distance

The text is explicitly grounded in Vidyapati's padavali, which participates in both the shringara (erotic) and bhakti (devotional) traditions. The selection of songs from the Nepal Padavali—songs concerned with separation, longing, and the precariousness of the woman awaiting her lover's return—situates the work within the viraha aesthetic that unites Sanskrit poetics with the devotional literatures of North India.

From the perspective of Abhinavagupta's dhvani theory, the vyangya (suggested meaning) of these songs transcends the literal narrative of a woman waiting for a migrant husband. The bidesiya becomes metaphor: for the soul separated from the divine, for the Mithila region alienated from its cultural roots, for the Maithili language itself in an age of displacement. When Vidyapati appears on stage to "explain the meaning," however, the text risks what the rasa tradition would consider a fundamental error: vibhava (determinants) and anubhava (consequents) are being made explicit rather than allowed to generate rasa through suggestion. The poet-character's hermeneutic interventions flatten the polysemy of the original verses.

A Bhakti reading would be more forgiving. In the devotional traditions of North India, the rasa of separation is itself a form of communion. The yuvati is Radha; the pia desantar is Krishna; the waiting is the soul's longing for union with the divine. The presence of Vidyapati as poet-saint reinforces this reading: he is not merely a commentator but a sant whose verses are themselves forms of sadhana (spiritual practice). The play's performance context—with troupes named after Ram and groups staging these plays as acts of devotion—supports this interpretation.

Yet the text's own framing pulls against devotional closure. The final lines, spoken of the concept of Piya Desantar, "presented before the discerning audience" and "offered with deep respect," maintain a critical distance. The play is neither fully devotional theater (bhakti rangmanch) nor fully secular folk drama (lok natya). This hybridity is productive but also, at times, unstable.

## IV. Intertextuality and the Anxiety of Influence

The text's relationship to Bhikhari Thakur's Bidesiya is its most significant intertextual engagement. Harold Bloom's Anxiety of Influence provides a useful framework: the Maithili text struggles to carve out a space distinct from its Bhojpuri predecessor while inevitably being shaped by it.

The author claims that Maithili lacks the sukshma vivaran (microscopic detail) of the Bhojpuri Bidesiya, citing Salahes and Chudamal as examples of narratives that "transcend regional boundaries" but have not been adequately researched. This is a claim about the canon: that Maithili folk literature has been neglected in favor of Sanskritized epic traditions. The present play can be read as an attempt to perform a kind of canonical critique, recovering what has been marginalized.

Yet the play's reliance on Vidyapati—the most canonized figure in Maithili literature—complicates this project. The author is, in effect, using the most prestigious Maithili literary figure to authorize a folk tradition that Vidyapati's own work may have historically marginalized. This is a postcolonial gesture of retrieval, but it also reveals the difficulty of accessing the "folk" without the mediation of elite literary forms.

A reader-response critic would note that the text's explicit framing of its own project—the lengthy prose introduction, the detailed descriptions of troupes, the citation of Nagendranath Gupta's edition—creates a specific reading contract. The audience is not being invited to experience rasa unmediated but to understand the process of construction, the archival labor, the politics of regional literary traditions. This meta-theatrical dimension is the play's most distinctive contribution.

## V. Performance Studies and the Question of Spectatorship

As a performance text, Vidyapati's Bidesiya exists in a liminal space. It is neither a complete script nor a performance record. The stage directions are

minimal: "The poet Vidyapati enters," "The young woman opens a shop, symbolically," "Darkness spreads." A performance studies scholar would ask: what is being documented here? The lila (play) of a specific troupe? A reconstruction of a lost tradition? Or a script for future performance?

The text's detailed attention to the raga (melodic mode) of each song—Dhanashi, Malava, Kolara, Ghanashi—suggests musical specificity. But without notation or performance instructions, these remain nominal. The playwright, or documenter, seems to assume a reader who knows these musical traditions intimately—a reader who is, in other words, already within the Maithili performance culture.

This raises questions about audience address. Who is this text for? The English translation that accompanies this critical exercise suggests an audience beyond Maithili speakers. Yet the text itself never translates the songs within the play; the Maithili original is presented, and the "meaning" is provided in Maithili prose (in the original document, which I have now translated into English for this response). The layering of languages and translations creates what Homi Bhabha would call a "third space"—neither fully Maithili nor fully English, neither performance nor documentation, neither folk nor classical.

## VI. The Politics of Literary Comparison

The author's comparative remarks about Bhojpuri and Maithili demand attention from a sociocritical perspective. "Bhojpuri literature is less rich than Maithili in terms of quantity," the text asserts, "but in terms of quality, it surpasses Maithili in several domains." This is a provocative claim that, if unpacked, reveals the entrenched hierarchies within north Indian literary cultures.

Maithili has a classical literary tradition dating back to Vidyapati (14th-15th centuries), a recognized grammar (Maithili Vyakaran), and a long history of scholarly production. Bhojpuri, despite its massive number of speakers, has

been historically stigmatized as a dialect rather than a language, its literary traditions marginalized by both Hindi and Maithili elites. The author's claim that Bhojpuri is "superior" in certain qualitative domains—specifically the Bidesiya tradition—is a strategic inversion of these hierarchies. It claims for Bhojpuri what has been denied: aesthetic sophistication, emotional depth, and cultural value.

Yet the text does not fully theorize this inversion. It remains caught in the comparative framework it seeks to challenge. A truly decolonial criticism would ask: why compare at all? Why not allow each tradition its own aesthetic criteria, its own standards of value? The comparison risks reinscribing the very hierarchies it critiques.

## VII. Unresolved Questions and Generative Ambiguities

The text leaves several questions unresolved, and these silences are, for the critic, productive:

1. The status of Vidyapati: Is he a character within the drama, the author of the source material, a sutradhara figure, or a devotional presence? The text's answer is "all of the above," and this multiplicity is both its strength and its weakness.

2. The relationship between the seven scenes: The scenes seem to present variations on a single situation—a woman, a traveler, the memory of a departed beloved. But do they constitute a narrative progression? A ritual cycle? A series of aesthetic variations (prakara)? The text does not say.

3. The politics of gender: The young woman's voice dominates the songs, but her agency remains constrained. She cannot refuse the traveler, cannot leave, cannot speak directly to her husband. The text reproduces this constraint without commentary. Is this fidelity to the source material, or a failure of critical distance?

4. The role of the sister-in-law: In the later scenes, she disappears, replaced by the traveler and the young woman alone. What happens to this relationship? The text's silence is suggestive but also incomplete.

5. The ending: The final "dissolve" into Piya Desantar is ambiguous. Is it union with the beloved? Death? Theatrical illusion collapsing? The text withholds interpretation, perhaps deliberately.

## VIII. Conclusion: Toward a Critical Reception

I will value certain things: formal coherence, thematic complexity, the productive tension between tradition and innovation. By these criteria, Vidyapati's Bidesiya is a work of considerable interest but also of unresolved contradictions.

Its greatest strength lies in its interstitial position: between folk and classical, Maithili and Bhojpuri, performance and text, devotion and critique. This position allows it to stage the very tensions that define modern Maithili identity—caught between a glorious literary past and a present of economic precarity, between Sanskritized prestige and folk vitality, between the ache of viraha and the demand for political recognition.

Its greatest weakness is its theoretical under-elaboration. The text knows what it wants to do—recover a tradition, honor Vidyapati, speak to the present moment of Maithili migration—but it does not always know how it is doing it. The generic instability, the ambiguous staging, the unresolved role of Vidyapati as character: these are not flaws per se, but they demand a reflexive account that the text does not provide.

A reception-oriented critic would note that this text now exists in multiple contexts: for Maithili readers, it is a document of cultural memory; for English

readers, a translated curiosity; for the scholar of Indian theater, a case study in the challenges of archiving performance traditions. Each reading context produces a different text.

Ultimately, Vidyapati's Bidesiya succeeds in what it perhaps most fundamentally attempts: to place the experience of the Maithili bidesiya—the migrant, and the woman who waits—within the most prestigious literary tradition Mithila possesses. In doing so, it makes a claim: that the suffering of labor migration deserves the same aesthetic attention as the viraha of Radha and Krishna; that the lok (folk) belongs within the shastra (classical tradition); that the contemporary moment of displacement demands the resources of a centuries-old poetic language.

Whether the text fully achieves this claim remains, for the critic, an open question. But the claim itself—and the labor of its articulation—demands respect.

## Critical Reading of Vidyapati's Bidesiya Through Five Theoretical Lenses

### I. Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak: Can the Maithili Subaltern Speak?

Spivak's foundational question—"Can the subaltern speak?"—interrogates the mechanisms by which marginalized subjects are represented within hegemonic discourse, always already mediated by institutional and ideological structures that preclude authentic self-expression. Vidyapati's Bidesiya presents a compelling case study for Spivakian analysis precisely because it stages the very crisis of representation her work theorizes.

The yuvati (young woman) who dominates the play's songs appears, on the surface, as a subaltern figure: a rural woman whose husband has migrated for labor, left to negotiate the precariousness of her position within patriarchal and economic structures that offer her no agency. Yet her speech—the songs she sings—is not her own. These are Vidyapati's verses, composed by a male poet

of the 14th-15th centuries, mediated through multiple textual transmissions (the Nepal Padavali, Nagendranath Gupta's collection), and further mediated by the contemporary playwright/documenter who selects, arranges, and frames them. The yuvati speaks, but what she speaks is already a citation of elite male-authored literature.

Spivak's critique of the "epistemic violence" of colonialism extends here to the internal colonialisms within Indian literary culture. The playwright's framing—that Maithili lacks the "microscopic detail" of Bhojpuri folk narrative—reveals an anxiety about authentic folk expression that the play attempts to resolve by recovering Vidyapati's verses as a kind of proto-folk archive. But Spivak would ask: what is erased in this recovery? The real Maithili women who have migrated, or waited for migrants, are replaced by a literary construct—the virahini (woman in separation) of Sanskritized poetics. The subaltern woman becomes a figure for something else: Maithili cultural identity, the prestige of the literary tradition, the authority of the poet-saint.

The play's final gesture—the ambiguous appearance of Piya Desantar (the beloved returned from abroad) emerging from darkness—is particularly instructive through a Spivakian lens. Is this union? Liberation? The text leaves it unresolved. But Spivak would note that the subaltern woman's desire is ultimately displaced onto the male figure's return. The yuvati's waiting finds its fulfillment not in her own agency but in the beloved's arrival. Her subjectivity is constituted entirely in relation to his absence and his presence. She speaks, but she speaks of him, for him, to him. Her own voice, like her own desire, remains mediated.

The playwright's own position mirrors the problematic Spivak identifies. As an educated, presumably urban, presumably male or male-identified figure who documents and frames these rural performance traditions, the playwright performs the very act of representation that Spivak critiques. The lengthy prose introduction—with its archival details of troupes, villages, and performance histories—functions as a claim to ethnographic authority. But does this documentation enable subaltern speech or foreclose it? The yuvati sings, but her songs are annotated, translated, interpreted—first by Vidyapati as character within the play, then by the playwright's framing, then by this critic. Each layer of mediation distances us further from any unmediated subaltern voice.

Spivak would remind us that the desire to "let the subaltern speak" is itself a Western-intellectual fantasy, a project of recovering authenticity that inevitably reproduces the structures it seeks to dismantle. Vidyapati's Bidesiya does not escape this paradox, but it stages it with unusual self-awareness. When Vidyapati the character appears to "explain the meaning" of the yuvati's songs, the play allegorizes the critic's own act. The question is whether the play recognizes this allegory as a problem, or whether it naively celebrates the poet's hermeneutic authority.

## II. Dipesh Chakrabarty: Provincializing the Maithili Literary Imaginary

Chakrabarty's Provincializing Europe argues that historicism—the European mode of writing history that assumes a universal, linear temporality—has structured modern South Asian thought in ways that foreclose other forms of temporal experience. Chakrabarty calls for a historiography that makes room for "the politics of the gods" and other modes of being that cannot be assimilated to secular, developmental time.

Vidyapati's Bidesiya offers a rich site for applying Chakrabarty's framework because it operates within multiple, incommensurable temporalities simultaneously. The play is about pravas (migration), which is a modern economic phenomenon: the text notes that migration in Mithila is "a recent phenomenon," that "villages stand deserted." Yet the play's aesthetic resources for representing this modern condition are drawn from Vidyapati's 14th-century padavali, which belongs to a pre-modern, devotional-erotic tradition. The yuvati who waits for her migrant husband is simultaneously a contemporary Maithili woman and Radha waiting for Krishna. The text does not choose between these temporalities; it inhabits both at once.

Chakrabarty would recognize this as a refusal of historicism's demand for chronological purity. The play refuses to say: "Here is the pre-modern viraha tradition; here is the modern migration narrative." Instead, it insists that the modern experience of labor migration is a form of viraha, that the contemporary

precarity of the Maithili migrant is the eternal longing of the soul for its beloved. This is not a metaphorical substitution but a temporal superposition: two times existing in the same space.

The text's comparison between Maithili and Bhojpuri literary traditions also invites a Chakrabartian reading. The playwright claims that Bhojpuri's Bidesiya tradition is "superior" in certain qualitative domains, while Maithili remains tied to "bojhil" (cumbersome) epic narratives. This is, among other things, a claim about literary time. Bhojpuri, the argument implies, has produced a modern, responsive, vernacular realism (Bhikhari Thakur's poignant songs of migrant suffering), while Maithili remains mired in the "heavy" forms of the Sanskritic past. The play's project—using Vidyapati to speak to the present—can be read as an attempt to provincialize the historicist assumption that "modern" forms (realism, the novel, secular narrative) are the only adequate vehicles for representing modern experience.

But Chakrabarty would also caution against romanticizing this temporal hybridity. The play's invocation of Vidyapati's authority—the poet-saint who validates the bidesiya tradition—risks reproducing the Brahminical prestige structures that have historically marginalized folk expression. The yuvati's songs become acceptable, perhaps, because they are Vidyapati's songs. The modern migrant's suffering becomes aesthetically legitimate because it is framed by a canonical literary tradition. Chakrabarty would ask: can we have a politics of the present that does not require the authorization of the pre-modern sacred?

The play's performance context—troupes named after Ram, plays staged as acts of devotion—suggests an answer. For the practitioners of the Ramkhelavan Mandal, Vidyapati is not an authority invoked to legitimize modern concerns; he is a living presence within a continuous devotional practice. The distinction between "modern" and "pre-modern" may not exist for them in the way it exists for the literate critic. Chakrabarty would urge us to take this seriously: to recognize that the temporality of the Ramkhelavan tradition is not historicist time but ritual time, cyclical time, the time of lila (divine play). Provincializing Europe means provincializing the historicist assumptions that make us see Vidyapati's presence as an anachronism rather than a continuity.

## III. A.K. Ramanujan: The Interplay of Folk and Classical Canons

Ramanujan's life work was devoted to challenging the hierarchical opposition between "folk" and "classical" traditions in Indian literature. He demonstrated that these categories are not fixed essences but dynamic, mutually constitutive formations. The "classical" continually draws on "folk" resources; the "folk" internalizes and transforms "classical" forms. Ramanujan's translations of Speaking of Śiva, The Interior Landscape, and Folktales from India exemplify his method: treating folk traditions with the same seriousness as canonical texts, attending to their formal sophistication and cultural complexity.

Vidyapati's Bidesiya is, in many ways, a Ramanujan-esque text. It explicitly concerns the relationship between Vidyapati—the most canonical figure in Maithili literature—and the folk performance traditions of the bidesiya. The playwright notes that Vidyapati's padavali includes "pure Bidesiya" verses, particularly those from the Nepal Padavali, suggesting that the classical poet was himself engaged with folk themes and forms. The performance troupes described—the Ramkhelavan Mandal, the Ramraksha Choudhary Natyakala Parishad—represent the ongoing life of these verses in popular performance contexts. The text refuses to separate the "high" literary tradition from the "low" performance tradition.

Ramanujan would be particularly interested in the play's treatment of translation—not only linguistic translation but the translation between genres, registers, and social worlds. The yuvati's songs move between shringara (erotic) and viraha (separation), between the classical raga system (Dhanashi, Malava, Kolara, Ghanashi) and the vernacular idiom of the stage directions. Vidyapati the character appears to "explain the meaning," performing the function of the scholar-commentator who mediates between classical text and popular reception. Yet this mediation is not one-directional: the yuvati also interprets the verses, "elaborating on its meaning" after Vidyapati sings. Meaning is not fixed by the classical authority but emerges through dialogic performance.

Ramanujan's concept of "context-sensitive" meaning—his insistence that Indian literary forms must be understood within their performance contexts—is crucial for reading this text. The play is not a "text" in the Western sense but a script-for-performance, a document that points toward an embodied, musical, ritual event. The detailed attention to raga, the stage directions that mark entrances and exits, the interactions between characters and audience (the traveler gestures toward the audience in Scene 7)—all indicate a performance tradition that cannot be reduced to its literary content.

Ramanujan would also note the text's engagement with regional specificity. The playwright's careful documentation of troupes from Samastipur, Purnia, Supaul, Saharsa—the naming of villages, panchayats, post offices—is not mere antiquarianism. It is a claim about place: that this tradition belongs to specific communities in specific locations, that its meanings are embedded in local geographies and histories. This regional grounding challenges the universalizing tendencies of both classical Sanskrit aesthetics and Western literary theory.

Yet Ramanujan would also note the absence that haunts this text. The playwright laments that "no research has been conducted" on folk figures like Salahes and Chudamal, that Maithili lacks the detailed folk narratives found in Bhojpuri. This is, in Ramanujan's terms, a failure of the canon to recognize its folk sources. The classical Maithili tradition has, perhaps, absorbed folk materials without acknowledging them, transforming them into "bojhil" epic forms that obscure their vernacular origins. The play's project—recovering the bidesiya within Vidyapati's padavali—is an attempt to reverse this process, to show that the classical poet was also a folk poet, that the canonical text contains within it the voices of women, migrants, and the dispossessed.

## IV. Rustom Bharucha: The Politics of Indian Theater and Performance

Bharucha's work has consistently challenged the appropriation of Indian performance traditions by both Western-oriented "modern" theater and state-sponsored "folk" revival movements. In Theatre and the World and The Politics

of Cultural Practice, Bharucha argues for a rigorous attention to the specific contexts, communities, and power relations within which performance traditions exist. He is skeptical of "intercultural" theater that extracts aesthetic forms from their social moorings, and critical of the ways "folk" traditions are repackaged for urban, middle-class, or international audiences.

Vidyapati's Bidesiya exists precisely in the contested space Bharucha maps. The text documents performance traditions—the Ramkhelavan Mandal, the Ramraksha Choudhary Natyakala Parishad—that have historically been rooted in rural Maithili communities. These troupes performed for local audiences, in village settings, as part of ritual and devotional cycles. Yet the text as we have it is a documentation, a translation, a presentation "before the discerning audience"—which is to say, before an audience that is not necessarily the original village community. The play, in its current form, has been extracted from its original performance context and offered to a different public: readers of Maithili, perhaps, but also (through translation) English-speaking scholars and students.

Bharucha would ask: what is lost in this extraction? The stage directions in the text are minimal: "On stage, our Bidesiya is bidding farewell," "The young woman opens a shop, symbolically." For someone who has never seen the Ramkhelavan Mandal perform, these directions offer only the barest suggestion of what the performance might have looked like, sounded like, felt like. The raga are named but not notated; the movement is indicated but not choreographed; the audience interaction is noted but not described. The text becomes a kind of ghost of the performance, preserving some information while losing the embodied, sensory, communal dimensions that Bharucha insists are irreducible.

Bharucha would also question the framing of these traditions within a literary-critical apparatus. The lengthy prose introduction—with its comparisons between Maithili and Bhojpuri, its citations of Nagendranath Gupta's edition, its positioning of Vidyapati within the bidesiya tradition—constitutes an academic framing that may be alien to the original practitioners. The play is presented as "a parallel universe" to Vidyapati's Bidesiya, a phrase that suggests a literary-intertextual relationship rather than a living performance tradition. Bharucha would ask: who is this text for? And whose interests does it serve?

The play's relationship to the Bidesiya tradition of Bhikhari Thakur is particularly significant from Bharucha's perspective. The playwright notes that Bhikhari Thakur's Bidesiya emerged from his own experience as a migrant in Calcutta and his performances for Bhojpuri-speaking communities. It was, in Bharucha's terms, a community-based theater: rooted in the lived experience of its practitioners and audiences, responsive to their needs and concerns. The present text's attempt to create a Maithili Bidesiya through Vidyapati's verses is, by contrast, a literary construction: it draws authority from a canonical poet rather than from contemporary experience. Bharucha would ask whether this substitution—classical viraha for modern migration—does justice to the specific suffering of contemporary Maithili migrants, or whether it aestheticizes that suffering in ways that distance it from its material reality.

The text's final gesture—"This concept of Piya Desantar is thus presented before the discerning audience. Amidst the current plight of the Maithili migrants (Bidesiya), this offering is presented with deep respect to the great poet, Vidyapati"—reveals the tension Bharucha identifies. The "plight" of migrants is acknowledged but then displaced: the offering is made to Vidyapati, not to the migrants themselves. The "discerning audience" is invited to appreciate the aesthetic concept rather than to respond to the social condition. Bharucha would insist that a truly political theater would not allow this displacement; it would insist on the primacy of the material suffering over the aesthetic framing.

## V. Edward Said: Traveling Theory and the Question of Origins

Said's concept of "traveling theory" addresses how ideas, texts, and practices move across cultural and historical contexts, inevitably being transformed in the process. In "Traveling Theory" and its reconsideration in "Traveling Theory Reconsidered," Said argues that theories lose and gain force as they travel, that their meaning is shaped by the contexts they enter, and that the question of "origins" is always complicated by these movements. His later work on late

style also offers resources for thinking about how traditions are received, adapted, and reanimated by later practitioners.

Vidyapati's Bidesiya is a text deeply concerned with origins and their complications. The playwright traces the tradition through multiple genealogies: the Ramkhelavan Mandal from Katghatra, the Ramraksha Choudhary Natyakala Parishad from Gayaghat, the Piya Desantar team from Purnia. These are claims to authenticity, to origins that ground the tradition in specific communities and places. Yet the text also acknowledges that the bidesiya tradition itself is a traveling one: it moves from Purnia to Supaul, Saharsa, Samastipur; it travels from Nepal (the Nepal Padavali) to Bihar; it travels from Vidyapati's 14th-century court to 21st-century village performances.

Said would be interested in how the text handles the Bhojpuri origin of the Bidesiya tradition. Bhikhari Thakur's Bidesiya is acknowledged as a prior, influential text—so much so that the Maithili text must define itself against it. The playwright's claim that Bhojpuri is "superior" in certain qualitative domains is, in Said's terms, an acknowledgment of the force of the traveling tradition. The Maithili text cannot ignore Bhikhari Thakur; it must contend with him, absorb him, define itself through and against him. This is the anxiety of influence, but also the productive dynamic of traveling theory: the Bhojpuri Bidesiya travels to Maithili and forces a rethinking of what Maithili literary tradition can do.

The text's use of Vidyapati—a figure from the 14th-15th centuries—to respond to a modern Bhojpuri tradition is itself a form of traveling theory. Vidyapati's padavali travels from its original courtly-devotional context to the contemporary performance context of the Maithili bidesiya. The poet-saint becomes, in this new context, something he never was: a chronicler of labor migration. This is not a "misreading" in any simple sense but a creative appropriation, a reanimation of a tradition to meet new needs. Said would recognize this as the vitality of traveling theory: ideas gain new force when they move into new contexts, even (or especially) when those contexts were not anticipated by their originators.

The text's concern with research—its lament that "no research has been conducted" on figures like Salahes and Chudamal—reveals a different kind of traveling theory: the movement of academic knowledge practices into folk traditions. The playwright, situated within or addressing a literate, academic context, brings the values of archival research, textual criticism, and historical documentation to bear on performance traditions that may not have operated according to these values. Said would note that this is not a neutral act; it transforms the traditions it seeks to document, subjecting them to criteria (like "research") that originate elsewhere.

Finally, Said's concept of "contrapuntal reading" offers a way to understand the text's multiple, overlapping origins. The play is simultaneously: a document of Ramkhelavan Mandal's performance tradition; a reconstruction of Vidyapati's bidesiya verses; a response to Bhikhari Thakur's Bhojpuri Bidesiya; a contribution to Maithili literary culture; a performance text for future stagings; and an object of academic study. These are not competing origins but coexisting ones, layered like musical lines in a contrapuntal composition. To privilege one origin over another—to say that the "real" text is the Ramkhelavan Mandal's performance, or Vidyapati's verses, or the playwright's creation—would be to deny the text's fundamental condition as a traveling, transformed, multiply-rooted cultural object.

## Synthesis: Convergences and Divergences

These five theoretical lenses, while distinct in their origins and commitments, converge on several key insights about Vidyapati's Bidesiya:

1. The Problem of Mediation: Spivak, Chakrabarty, and Said all, in different ways, emphasize that the subaltern, the pre-modern, the "original" are always already mediated. The yuvati does not speak except through Vidyapati; Vidyapati does not speak except through performance traditions; performance traditions do not speak except through documentation. The text is a meditation on mediation itself.

2. The Politics of Recovery: Ramanujan and Bharucha both question the project of "recovering" folk traditions through classical frameworks. For Ramanujan, the classical and folk are always already intertwined; for Bharucha, recovery can be a form of appropriation. The text's attempt to claim Vidyapati for the bidesiya tradition is simultaneously a radical democratization of the canon and a potential erasure of the distinctiveness of folk practice.

3. Temporality and History: Chakrabarty and Said both challenge linear, historicist accounts of cultural development. The text's superposition of Vidyapati's viraha and modern migration, its insistence that the 14th-century poet speaks to the 21st-century condition, refuses the historicist assumption that each era has its own appropriate aesthetic forms. This is not anachronism but a different relationship to time.

4. The Question of Audience: Spivak asks who speaks; Bharucha asks for whom. The text's multiple audiences—village performance communities, Maithili readers, English-language scholars—complicate any simple answer. The play exists in different forms for different publics, and these different existences are not reducible to a single "original."

5. The Limits of Theory: Each of these theorists would also remind us that theory has its limits. Spivak's subaltern cannot finally speak; Chakrabarty's non-historicist temporalities are difficult to represent within academic prose; Ramanujan's folk-classical synthesis cannot be fully captured by scholarly categories; Bharucha's embodied performance eludes documentation; Said's traveling theory always risks becoming another form of appropriation. Vidyapati's Bidesiya may succeed precisely in its refusal to resolve these tensions, its insistence on remaining multiple, partial, and unfinished.

## Concluding Reflection

As a reader trained in these theoretical traditions, I find myself both illuminated and unsettled by Vidyapati's Bidesiya. The text offers itself as an offering to

Vidyapati, as a document of folk tradition, as a response to contemporary migration, as a performance script. It resists the kind of theoretical mastery that would pin it down to a single meaning, a single origin, a single audience. Perhaps this is its greatest strength: not that it resolves the tensions between classical and folk, text and performance, past and present, but that it stages these tensions with an honesty that theoretical critique can only echo.

The five theorists I have invoked would, I think, each recognize something of their own concerns in this text. Spivak would see the subaltern's mediated speech; Chakrabarty would see non-historicist temporality; Ramanujan would see the classical-folk continuum; Bharucha would see the politics of performance documentation; Said would see traveling theory in action. But none would claim that the text is reducible to their framework. The text exceeds theory, as cultural objects always do. That excess is what makes it worthy of critical attention—and what makes the critic's work always provisional, always incomplete, always open to further reading.

Annexure-3 [Vidyapati, the Primal Poet of Maithili (Pre-Jyotirishvara)]

Translation from Maithili to English

Vidyapati, the Primal Poet of Maithili (Pre-Jyotirishvara)

Original Maithili: Gajendra Thakur

Maithili to English: Gajendra Thakur

Vidyapati: Refutation of Certain Prevalent Misconceptions

Vidyapati of the Parallel Tradition and the Pag (Headgear)

In Vidyapati's Sanskrit works, it is written "composed by Thakkura Vidyapati," and that Vidyapati is a Brahmin. My concern, however, is with the Vidyapati who wrote in Maithili… Regarding this, I have discussed why he was made "our Vidyapati" by placing a pag (traditional headgear) upon him. This did not occur when the Brahmin community preserved Vidyapati for eight hundred years through the medium of Bidapat Nach (Vidyapati dance-drama). Rather, it happened when Bengal claimed Vidyapati and Govindadas as its own, and the Bengali scholar Rajkrishna Mukhopadhyay first stated that Vidyapati was a poet of the Maithili language, and Nagendranath Gupta of Bengal first stated that Govindadas was also a poet of the Maithili language. When this fact came to light, all of Bengal first rose up in opposition, then later accepted it. Thereafter, the scholars of Mithila were stirred into action, and drawing upon Vidyapati's Sanskrit works, and upon records available in the Panji (genealogical registers) under the names Govindadas and Vidyapati, they produced a Vidyapati Thakur and a Govindadas Jha (!!!)—the superficial knowledge and limited perspective of Ramanath Jha's Panji caused considerable damage. Subsequently, inadvertently, Vidyapati (the Maithili poet, not the Sanskrit one) was made "our Vidyapati" by the Brahmin class, by placing a pag upon him. Some even began addressing him as the nephew of Jyotirishvara!

But there are many poets contemporary with or prior to the poet-king Jyotirishvara (c. 1275-1350) available in the Panji. And if the discrepancies in names that appear in Vidyapati's case (while a piece of evidence remains, suggesting all this was done with planning) do not appear in the case of Jyotirishvara, why is that?

Ram Thakur

When I went to Bengal and traveled to Purnia for the worship of village deities, I saw Ram Thakur (the Lord) worshipped as a deity in a plowed field, someone having lit a lamp there.

Prabhat Jha, a Rajya Sabha MP from Madhya Pradesh, who had traveled from Mithila to Chhattisgarh and Madhya Pradesh, once told me that when carpenters (barhi) from Mithila went there, people began calling them "Jhaji" because they were Maithili speakers, and now they bear the title "Jha." Prabhat Jha campaigned for them, and one candidate won by a single vote. My own experience tells me that regardless of one's title, people in Patna and elsewhere will call a person "Jhaji" or "Jhaua." In the Malda district of Bengal, there are four or five villages where the title for Maithil Brahmins is "Ojha," and in Aligarh, among Maithil Brahmins (Brajastha Maithils), the title is "Sharma."

## How Many Entries of Vidyapati Are There in the Panji?

Numerous entries of Vidyapati are available in the Panji:

1. Vidyapati—marriage of Ramapati, son of Panichobha, to Vidyapati—mother (devadasi)—Dushan Panji
2. Maho Keshavo's son Mahamahopadhyaya Govind's daughter Maho Lakshminath Mahamahopadhyaya Vidyapati Mahamahopadhyaya Damodar
3. From Mahamaho Vidyapati Gangoli—residents of Manakudha, the poet-king Ganeshvara
4. From Ghosaut—Mahamahopadhyaya Govind's daughter Maha Lakshmidhara Mahamahopadhyaya Vidyapati
5. Royal Pandit Mahamahopadhyaya Vidyapati
6. From Karamaha—Devnath's son, the poet Vidyapati
7. Gunapati's lineage—Pathonghi. Vidyapati—Pudarika—Machhadi. Keshava—Amaravati.
8. From Singhashram—Vidyapati (second generation): Bhagirath's sons Kuleshvara
9. Sidhuka's daughters were given to Vishvanath and Shrinath; from Singhashram, Vidyapati, two

10. From Mishra Jayadev's daughter Nagavad Ghosaut—Mahamahopadhyaya Vidyapati, two

11. Mahamahopadhyaya Govind's daughter Mahamaho Lakshminatha Paranamaka (209/05) Thakkura Mahamahopadhyaya Vidyapati

12. Two—thus Thakkura Vidyapati Matrika Chakra

13. Mahamahopadhyaya Vidyapati's sons Aniruddha, Ananta, Achyuta; from Ekahara, to Kashi, two

14. Sadu's son Damodar's son Daluka; from Pavali, to Godhi (second generation); Dalu (34/06)'s son Vidyapati

15. Sons Shiru, Padam, Lakhu, Gaduka; from Ekahara, Shri Kar's son Chand (second generation); from Khaual, Bhule (second generation); Madhusudan's son Umapati (84/01) Vidyapati

16. From Musai, Khaual—Dalu's son Vidyapati (second generation); from Bhandarisam, Shubhe (second generation), Thakkura

17. From Sodarpur—Chhotai (second generation) (28/08); Basaun's son Pashupati Vidyapati

18. Kalyan's son from Karamaha—Vidyapati, two

19. From Jalaya—Rameshvara's son Mahighara (second generation); from Yamugama—Genai (second generation); Vidyapati's son Bhagirath

20. Harkhu Govinda's son Gune's son Vidyapati (second generation); from Suragana, Hore, two

21. Krishnapati's son Murari Vidyapati Prajapati; from Takabal, Ramakar, two

22. Kavindra-padankita Mahamahopadhyaya Raghunatha from Karamaha—Vidyapati, two

23. Vidyapati's son from Mandar—Yagyapati, two

24. From Talhanpur—Gadhvaya (second generation); Vidyapati

25. Yashu's sons Ravipati, Rudrapati Vidyapati, Chandrapati

26. From Naraun—Vidyapati, two

27. Ravipati's son Krishnapati Vidyapati; from Ghusaut, Hore, two

28. Vidyapati's sons from Belaunch—Ram, two

29. Gune's sons Gauripati Vidyapati Lakshmipati Kulapatiya; from Dari, Divakar, two

30. Maternal grandfather of Mahipati Jha, the poet Kokila Vidyapati Thakkura; Damodar's son Pansadu Haridev; from Naraun, Mangani, two

31. Ganapati's son, the poet Kokila, Royal Pandit Mahamahopadhyaya Vidyapati; his sons Haripati Dhanapati

32. Mahamahopadhyaya Vidyapati's son Hrishikesh

33. Harapati's son Vidyapati; from Kashi, Damodara

34. Ratipati's son Sodara Vidyapati, two

35. Vidyapati's great-grandson, grandson Harishvara Dhaneshvara's son Gonduka; from Pali, Jnanada, two

36. Vidyapati (second generation); Veni's son Ravinath

37. Sodara Vidyapati (second generation); Nikara

38. Shripati's son Vidyapati; from Parana, Darihara

39. Sodara Vidyapati (second generation); Mishra Kamalnayan's daughter from Hariam, Bachhai, two

40. From Ravaual, Sone (second generation); Devnath's son, the poet Vidyapati; from Pachhi Sodarpur, Jagannath, two

41. Gopi's son Vidyapati Vachaspati Shiva; from Hariam, Narayan, two

42. Vidyapati Nidhi Pra. Dharapatiya

43. Tarauni from Karamaha—Mahidhara (second generation) (46/03) Vidyapati (111/03)'s son Madhusudan

44. Kulananda Hridayanandana Kara; from Panai (second generation) (109/106) Vidyapati (314/05)'s sons Pritinath, Shobhanath, Mahinath

45. Umapati's son Vidyapati's son Jayapati

46. Jago's sons Surapati, Haripati, Prabhapati, Girapati, Vidyapatiya

47. Hachalu's sons Harapati Vidyapati Maho Jnanapati Dinapati Manikamtha

48. Krishna's sons Ramapati, Shripati, Ratnapati, Vidyapati; from Budhval, Dhiru, two

49. Dase's son Dayori; from Khandabala, Gopinath (second generation) (85/02) Vidyapati's son Jivanath

50. From Naraun—Vidyapati, two

51. Dharmadhika Ranika Batu's son Vidyapati

52. From Sodarpur—Gayan (second generation); Vidyapati's sons Ramapati, Horila, Hararavu, Jivaika; from Mandar, Sodhu, two

53. From Khaual—Raghunath (second generation) (54/07) Vidyapati's son Janu

54. From Takabal—Vidyapati (second generation); Matinath

55. From Khandabala—Vidyapati's son Jivanath, two

56. From Karamaha—Vidyapati (second generation); Vishvanath

57. Krishnapati's son Umapati (Ba. 28/01) Vidyapati (302/03); from Pandua, Pan Bhagirath, two

58. Maho Harikrishna's daughter from Khaual—Vidyapati, two

59. Madhusudan's son Vidyapati; from Alaya, Aniruddha, two

60. From Mandar—Devasharma (second generation); Vidyapati's son from Naraun, Badani, two

61. Thakkura Shyama's son Purandara Paramananda; from Mandar—Vidyapati, two

62. Vidyapati's sons from Sodarpur—Jairam

63. Dharmeshvara from Khaual—Harai's son Manohar (second generation); Rudra's son Rama; from Gangoli—Deve (second generation); from Vishfi, the poet Kokila, Royal Pandit Mahamahopadhyaya Vidyapati (second generation); Rama's son Bhiravuka; from Fanandaha, Lochan (second generation); from Pakaliya, Dinu (second generation); Bhiravu's son Haraika; from Sodarpur, Vira's son Harida (second generation); from Khaual, Shubhe (second generation); Harai's sons Mohan, Manohara, Kamala, Narayana; from Sodarpur, Jagannath's son Bhavani (second generation); Bhavani's son Haridev Sadayaka; from Hariam, Govind's son Shridhara (second generation); Sako Jage (second generation); Manohar's daughter from Karamaha, Ratnapati's son Krishnadas (second generation); Krishnadas's daughter from Sodarpur, Madhusudan's son Sundara (second generation) (47/05); from Darihara, Mushai (second generation); Hari's son Pranapati; from Sodarpur, Narayan's son Nanu (second generation) (110/01) (101/01); Narayan's son Nanuka; from Budhval, Bahuri (second generation) (180/04); Damodar's son Bahurika; from Sodarpur, Paramananda's son Kangava (second generation); Paramananda's son Kangava; from Mandar, Halaghara's son Pitambara (second generation) (58/05); from Karamaha, Shriram (second generation); Kangava's daughter from Karamaha, Shivadev's son Karama (second generation); from Mandar, Vavu (second generation); Dauhitra, two

64. Vavu Durgapati Singh's son Vavu Vidyapati Singh; from Karamaha, Harinath's son Taranath, two

65. From Khaual—Yuvaraj (second generation); Vavu Vidyapati Singh's son Vavu Girijapati Singh

66. Vavu Gangapati Singh's sons Bheshapati Singh, Vidyapati Singh

67. Vavu Bheshapati Singh's wife from another caste; their son Hansapati Singh; Vavu Vidyapati Singh's son Raman Kumar Singh

68. Bala's son Bhaiya Kalyanau; from Khaual—Vidyapati, two

69. Vishvanath Kashinath; from Alaya—Vidyapati, two

70. Pathaka Vidyapati's son Dukhamanjana Kalarau; from Asi Ekahara, Umananda, two

71. Narapati's daughter from Kalyanpur Vishfi—Sundara (second generation); Kamalnayan's son Narayan's son Sundara; from Karamaha—Vidyapati, two

72. Murari's sons Damodara Vidyapati Mahighara Ananda

73. Vidyapati's sons Padmapati, Sabhapati, Adipati, Ganapatiya

74. Vidyapati's sons Chhitu, Paramananda; from Mandar, Narapati (second generation); from Baheradhi, Gadadhara, two

75. From Alaya—Kamala's son Nakatu (second generation); Vidyapati's son Jivanath's son Parama; from Dari, Rama, two

76. From Karamaha—Vidyapati's son Madhusudan, two

77. Mani from Sodarpur—Vachaspati's son Vidyapati, two

78. From Khandabala—Vavu Durgapati Singh's son Vavu Vidyapati Singh, two

79. From Khaual—Vidyapati (second generation); Thakkura Madhurapati's son Vachha Shivanandana

80. From Sodarpur—Vaidyanatha (second generation); Harikrishna's daughter from Khaual—Madhusudan's son Vidyapati, two

81. Madhusudan's son Vidyapati, two

82. From Darihara—Ramapati's son Veni (second generation); from Alaya—Krishnapati's son Vidyapati, two

83. From Alaya—Vidyapati, two

84. Jyotishivanandana's son Vidyapati

85. From Khaual—Bhavadev's son Vidyapati, two

86. Pathaka Krishnapati's son Ushapati Vidyapati

87. Vidyapati's son Dukhabhanjana Kalaro; from Ekahara, Devananda's son Umananda, two

88. From Alaya—Vidyapati's son Kalaru, two

89. Karu's sons Pitambara Vidyapati Devakimana; from Sodarpur, Vaidyanath's son Jayi, two

90. Suraoi Pra. Sharadananda's daughter Gaurinandana Vachaspati Pra. Vidyapati Divakara Pra. Mandu Ratnakara Pra. Bh. Bholan Ji's Nag. from Ghusaut—Damodar's son Ugramohana (second generation); from Ekahara, Shobhananda, two

91. From Khaual—Vidyapati (second generation)

Now, to the Core Issue

Among the Royal Pandits and numerous other Vidyapatis who held positions such as Dharmadhikaranika (judicial authorities), including one who was the son of a devadasi, there is no doubt whatsoever about their being Brahmins. I am not speaking of Vidyapati Thakkura and Kirtilata or Kirtipataka, but rather of the Vidyapati of the Padavali (lyrical poetry). So let us not remain confused.

Now, let us consider the Bidapat sung by the Gaer Brahmins (a non-elite Brahmin sub-group), who existed prior to Jyotirishvara (possibly) within the Barber caste, and evidence for this is found in Jyotirishvara's description in Ratnakara, where he discusses this poet and his works.

Mahadeva was originally a deity of the Gaer Brahmins; gradually, he was adopted by other Brahmins. In any composition of Vidyapati's Padavali, there is no mention of him being a Sanskrit or Avahattha writer. But why is the pain for the proletariat, which is present in his compositions (as distinct from those of the other Vidyapati who was a Brahmin and wrote in Sanskrit and Avahattha), absent in the works of the Sanskrit and Avahattha Vidyapati? Consider this example.

## Vidyapati's Bidesiya (The Exile's Song) – Piya Desantar and Bidapat Nach

While Bhojpuri literature is less abundant in quantity than Maithili, in terms of quality, it surpasses Maithili in several domains. I make this statement in the context of Bhikhari Thakur's Bidesiya in Bhojpuri. Bhikhari Thakur lived as a migrant in Calcutta, and upon his return, he wandered from village to village, singing and narrating his sufferings in such a poignant manner that his Bidesiya play was born. In Mithila, migration is a contemporary phenomenon; entire villages have been rendered desolate. The people of Mithila have spread across various parts of the country. However, earlier, the kind of large-scale migration seen in the Bhojpuri region did not occur in Mithila. Migration was limited to Morang, which is part of the Mithilanchal region of Nepal. Consequently, there is a significant dearth of detailed folk narratives in Maithili. Whatever exists is not the detailed account of a folk hero but rather the description of epic heroes in Maithili, which is elaborate and cumbersome, and not comparable to Bhikhari Thakur's Bidesiya. Take the narrative of Salahes, for instance. It transcends regional boundaries: Salahes transforms from king to thief, and from thief to king. Similarly, Chuhadmal, in crossing regional boundaries, becomes a thief where Salahes becomes a king, and is known as a king/powerful figure where Salahes is called a thief. But no research has been possible on these subjects.

In this context, while examining the verses of Vidyapati's Padavali, various types of songs came before me. Most of these were descriptions of the separation of lovers—far removed from the core concept of Bidesiya, which is migration born of economic necessity for sustenance and livelihood. It was then that I found some pure Bidesiya verses, which Vidyapati called Piya-desantar (Beloved gone to a foreign land). Most of these were naturally found in Vidyapati's Nepal Padavali, and one from Nagendranath Gupta's collection. Morang, being a part of Mithila located in Nepal and historically known for out-migration, is a likely reason for this.

Based on this foundation, Vidyapati's Piya Desantar was performed on stage.

Thus, Bidapat Nach and Piya Desantar are two plays based on Vidyapati's Padavali.

Amidst the current plight of the Maithili migrants (Bidesiya), this offering is presented with deep respect to the great poet, Vidyapati.

Is this pain present in the Vidyapati of Avahattha and Sanskrit?

The Padavali is a symbol of a parallel culture. In the same era, the same author could write in both Sanskrit and Avahattha, and he suffered because scholars mocked him for writing in Avahattha. But is there even a trace of this pain in the Vidyapati of the Padavali? In him, there is joy and sorrow—the joy and sorrow of the proletariat. That Vidyapati who wrote in Sanskrit and Avahattha was a Royal Pandit, a scholar; people ridiculed him for writing in Avahattha as well. But the Vidyapati of Maithili, who belongs to this parallel tradition, was far removed from such concerns. This parallel tradition has existed since the time of the Rigveda (the Narashamsi songs belong to that era). Whether this Vidyapati of the parallel tradition belonged to the Barber caste or the Brahmin caste remains a matter on which history is silent. However, folk tales and tradition, Bidapat's deep connection with the proletariat, and the traditions of Vishfi suggest he was a Gaer Brahmin. No verse in Sanskrit or Avahattha discusses this Vidyapati's Padavali, nor does the Padavali mention the Sanskrit or Avahattha compositions of Vidyapati. Sanskrit and Avahattha lament Muslim invasions, the defilement of the sacred thread, and the desecration of temples, but the Padavali embodies the joy, celebration, and struggle of the proletariat; such an outcry is absent there. And if the question arises whether the Vidyapati of Maithili was a Brahmin or not, what intention are we all fostering by placing a pag on his head? Was "Vidyapati" not ours? If Vidyapati was not a Brahmin, would he cease to be ours? Would his songs of migration, Piya Desantar, become insignificant? Is there a conspiracy behind discussing only his erotic songs? How appropriate is it to bind a poet like Vidyapati within caste strictures by placing a pag on his head? Vijay Kumar Thakur writes in Medieval Mithila: "The influence of this feudal-era religious ideology in the religious sphere of

Mithila was so pervasive that even today, the following remnants of this tradition persist in society: …(d) The pag is also associated with tantric ideology." (p. 26) So, this too is linked to tantra and ritual. Why then was this Vidyapati of the parallel tradition confined within this? Whether he belonged to the Barber caste or was a Brahmin (if he was a Brahmin, then more so, given the orthodoxy of 21st-century Brahmins), if a Brahmin of a thousand years ago belonged to a parallel tradition, then the feudal remnants like the pag were used only in tantric religious rituals, not placed upon Vidyapati's head).

Two Vidyapatis: Some Legends and Some Facts – Bodhi Kayastha and Ugna Mahadev

LESSON 006 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY

# Vidyapati, the Primal Poet of Maithili (Pre-Jyotirishvara)

(Vidyapati's portrait by Pankalal Mandal, awardee of the Videh Chitrakala Samman)

Prior to the poet-king Jyotirishvara (c. 1275-1350)—because Jyotirishvara's works mention him—the primal poet of Maithili. Distinct from Vidyapati Thakkura, who wrote in Sanskrit and Avahattha. Possibly the son of Shri Mahesh Thakur, of the Barber caste from Vishfi village. In the Bidapat Nach of the parallel tradition, the Vidyapati Padavali (from the pre-Jyotirishvara era) is performed through dance and drama.

Pre-Jyotirishvara Vidyapati: Abhinavagupta of Kashmir (late 10th to early 11th century) mentions Vidyapati in his work Ishvara Pratyabhijña Vimarshini. Shridhar Das's Sadukti Karnamrita (composed February 11, 1206, Medieval Mithila, V.K. Thakur) cites five verses by Vidyapati, which are in the language of Vidyapati's Padavali:

Jāva na mālato kara paragāsa

Tāve na tāhi madhukara vilāsa.

And

Mundalā mukula kataya makaranda

Jyotirishvara (1275-1350) mentions him in the Sixth Kallola – "Atha Vidyāvanta Varṇanā" and in the Eighth Kallola – "Atha Rājya Varṇanā."

In the Bidapat Nach of the parallel tradition, the Vidyapati Padavali (from the pre-Jyotirishvara era) is performed through dance and drama.

Vidyapati Thakkura (1350-1435), of Vishfe village, of the Kashyapa gotra, courtier of King Shivasimha, and author in Sanskrit and Avahattha. Author of timeless works including Kirtilata, Kirtipataka, Purusha Pariksha, Goraksha Vijaya, Likhanavali, among others. He is distinct from the primal poet of Maithili, Vidyapati (pre-Jyotirishvara).

Bodhi Kayastha

In Vidyapati Thakkura's Purusha Pariksha, the story of his attainment of the Ganges is narrated. This story was also in circulation regarding the great poet Vidyapati (the author of the pre-Jyotirishvara Maithili Padavali), and later became associated with Vidyapati Thakkura (the author in Sanskrit and Avahattha).

Ugna Mahadev

Mahadeva (in the form of Ugna) would disguise himself as a servant named Ugna to hear Vidyapati's songs at Ahitham. This story of Ugna became famous in connection with both the primal poet of Maithili, Vidyapati (pre-

Jyotirishvara), and Vidyapati Thakkura (the author in Sanskrit and Avahattha, courtier of King Shivasimha).

The Sacred Thread Ceremony and Pag Installation by the Mithila Sanskritik Parishad

The "Mithila Sanskritik Parishad" and those associated with it, like "Kishori Kant Mishra," either failed to understand or chose not to understand the distinction between Vidyapati Thakkura (of Sanskrit and Avahattha) and the poet Kokila Vidyapati. There is historical written evidence that Gonu Jha lived around 1050-1150, yet Usha Kiran Khan depicts him engaging in scholarly debate with the Sanskrit and Avahattha Vidyapati (in the Hindi historical novel Sirajanhara, Bharatiya Jnanpith). Virendra Jha states that Gonu Jha lived 500 years ago, while Taranand Viyogi believes Gonu Jha lived 300 years ago (both have published books on Gonu Jha in Hindi, from Rajkamal Prakashan and National Book Trust respectively), while Vibha Rani's Hindi book on Gonu Jha (Vani Prakashan) considers Kunal Gonu Jha to have lived during the reign of Bhava Simha (14th century). When the written records in the Panji document Gonu Jha ten generations prior to the Sanskrit and Avahattha Vidyapati, this is the situation.

Regarding the Vidyapati of the parallel tradition and the pag—in Vidyapati's Sanskrit works, it is written "composed by Thakkura Vidyapati," and that Vidyapati is a Brahmin. My concern is with the Vidyapati who wrote the Maithili Padavali. Why was he made "our Vidyapati" by placing a pag upon him? This did not occur when the Brahmin community preserved Vidyapati for eight hundred years through the medium of Bidapat Nach. It happened when Bengal claimed the Padavali of Vidyapati and Govindadas as its own, but the Bengali scholar Rajkrishna Mukhopadhyay first stated in 1875 AD that Vidyapati was a poet of Mithila, and Nagendranath Gupta of Bengal first stated that Govindadas was also a poet of Mithila. When this fact came to light, all of Bengal first rose up in opposition, then later accepted it.

When Rajkrishna Mukhopadhyay said Vidyapati belonged to Mithila, he was referring to the Vidyapati of the Padavali, not the Vidyapati Thakkura of Sanskrit and Avahattha—Bengal never claimed the latter as its own.

The Maithili songs included in Jyotirishvara's Sanskrit play Dhurtasamagama and in the Sanskrit and Avahattha Vidyapati's Goraksha Vijaya are indicative of the ancient tradition of the Padavali, and the influence of the Maithili Padavali can be observed on both these authors.

Then, the scholars of Mithila were stirred into action, and drawing upon Vidyapati's Sanskrit-Avahattha works and records available in the Panji under the names Govindadas and Vidyapati, they produced Vidyapati Thakur and Govindadas Jha (!!!), where the superficial knowledge and limited perspective of Ramanath Jha's Panji caused damage. Subsequently, inadvertently, by placing a pag on him (the Mithila Sanskritik Parishad—this organization, after India's independence, committed the reprehensible act of declaring Vidyapati a Brahmin by placing a pag on him), the Vidyapati of Maithili (not the Sanskrit one) was made "our Vidyapati" by the Brahmin class. But there are many poets contemporary with or prior to Jyotirishvara available in the Panji. And if the discrepancies in names that appear in Vidyapati's case (while a piece of evidence remains, suggesting all this was done with planning) do not appear in the case of Jyotirishvara, why is that?

Now, let us consider the Bidapat sung by the Gaer Brahmins, who existed prior to Jyotirishvara (possibly) within the Naua Thakur caste, and evidence for this is Jyotirishvara's description in Ratnakara, where he discusses this poet.

Vidyapati never mentions being a Sanskrit/Avahattha writer in any of his Padavali compositions. But why is the pain for the proletariat, which is present in his compositions (as distinct from the other Vidyapati who was a Brahmin and wrote in Sanskrit and Avahattha), absent in the works of the Sanskrit and Avahattha Vidyapati? The Sanskrit and Avahattha Vidyapati indeed despises the proletariat and is, in written form, an orthodox Brahmin.

But the Vidyapati of the Padavali is innocent; some orthodox verses have been inserted by orthodox Brahmin editors (laughably so).

The concept of Piya Desantar (Vidyapati's Bidesiya) is now before the discerning audience, and amidst the current plight of the Maithili migrants, this

offering is presented with deep respect to the great poet, Vidyapati. Is this pain present in the Vidyapati of Avahattha and Sanskrit?

However, folk tales and tradition, Bidapat's deep connection with the proletariat, and the traditions of Vishfi suggest he was a Gaer Brahmin. No verse in Sanskrit or Avahattha discusses this Vidyapati's Padavali, nor does the Padavali mention the Sanskrit or Avahattha compositions of Vidyapati. Sanskrit and Avahattha lament Muslim invasions, the defilement of the sacred thread, and the desecration of temples, but the Padavali embodies the joy, celebration, and struggle of the proletariat; such an outcry is absent there. During his time, Muslims rarely even resided in Mithila. And if the question arises whether the Vidyapati of Maithili was a Brahmin or not, what intention are we all fostering by placing a pag on his head? Was "Vidyapati" not ours? If Vidyapati was not a Brahmin, would he cease to be ours? Would his songs of migration, Piya Desantar, become insignificant? Is there a conspiracy behind discussing only his erotic songs? How appropriate is it to bind a poet like Vidyapati within caste strictures by placing a pag on his head? Vijay Kumar Thakur writes in Medieval Mithila: "The influence of this feudal-era religious ideology in the religious sphere of Mithila was so pervasive that even today, the following remnants of this tradition persist in society: …(d) The pag is also associated with tantric ideology." (p. 26)

So, this too is linked to tantra, marriage, and the sacred thread ceremony. Why then was this Vidyapati of the parallel tradition confined within this? And this reprehensible act was carried out by Kishori Kant Mishra's Mithila Sanskritik Parishad. If the language and culture of Mithila survive today despite such people who claim to be its protectors, it is due to the unique characteristics of that language and culture.

In the Chetna Samiti's journal, Maneshwar Manuj wrote in a biased statement that Jagdish Prasad Mandal had written only four novels!!!

If Jagdish Prasad Mandal did not have the title "Mandal" but was simply Jagdish Prasad, the followers of Ramanath Jha would have declared him a Shrotriya, the followers of Amar-Ramdev Jha would have declared him a

Brahmin, and Mr. Verma, the author of "Laldas's Souvenir," would have declared him a Kayastha.

And if a photograph of Jagdish Prasad Mandal were not available, the reactionary Mithila Sanskritik Parishad of Kishori Kant Mishra would have performed his sacred thread ceremony, placed a pag on him, and repeated the same reprehensible act they committed with Vidyapati after a thousand years. And some elderly person, seeing a clay pot, would have concocted a fictional genealogy for Jagdish Prasad "Jha/Thakkura" and declared it so.

The writings of Malangiya's son, Ramdev Jha's son, and numerous pseudonyms have been published in Videha without any editing—those that could be printed have been, and those that could not have not been. And out of fear of repercussions, historians of Maithili and Mithila have, to this day, only hinted at this subject but not advanced further.

Thus, it is again proven that there was a Vidyapati who preceded Jyotirishvara (1275-1350). The songs, dances, and kirtans of Jayadeva (c. 1200) align with the Padavali of the pre-Jyotirishvara Vidyapati, but do not align with the poetic sophistication of the Sanskrit and Avahattha Vidyapati.

Now, once again, to the platform of the Mithila Sanskritik Parishad. This Parishad did not perform Vidyapati's sacred thread ceremony; it performed the sacred thread ceremony of the Maithili language itself. The pag they placed on Vidyapati caused the disappearance of Bindhyeshwar Mandal and Shrikant Mandal from Calcutta, and the sacred thread ceremony of the Maithili language was thus completed.

Consider the caste orthodoxy of the Sanskrit and Avahattha Vidyapati:

In Kirtilata: Marriage between castes is considered low and foreign.

In Purusha Pariksha, while narrating a story, the author comments that Rajput women are characterless—this is akin to the statement in the Atharvaveda that a Shudra's wife can be taken by anyone without consent. In fact, no such statement ever appeared in the Atharvaveda or any Veda.

Shukla Yajurveda (26.2): Yathemaṃ vācaṃ kalyāṇīmāvadāni janebhyaḥ brahmarājanyābhyāṃ śūdrāya cāryāya ca svāya cāraṇāya ca —We shall speak this sacred Vedic speech to all: to the Brahmin, the Kshatriya, the Shudra, the Arya, to our own people, and to the stranger (i.e., to everyone). But contrary to this Vedic statement, the Manusmriti sought to prohibit the study or hearing of the Vedic speech for certain sections of society. However, even the Smriti accepts the Vedic word as authority (verbal testimony), so its own directive given in opposition to it becomes invalid.

But in Purusha Pariksha, it is present. And can you believe that the Sanskrit and Avahattha Vidyapati stooped so low as to write thus about the women of his own patron's caste?

The Sanskrit and Avahattha Vidyapati places special emphasis on caste and purity of blood; caste is important to him. He says that those of low lineage are not worthy of any compassion!! Beauty is also the monopoly of the wealthy and the elite!! The Sanskrit and Avahattha Vidyapati (the one whose sacred thread ceremony and pag were celebrated by Kishori Kant Mishra's Mithila Sanskritik Parishad) says: Caste is the ultimate determining factor in social life. One born in a bad lineage can only become a snake with a vile mind!! The Sanskrit and Avahattha Vidyapati (the one with the sacred thread and pag of Kishori Kant Mishra's Mithila Sanskritik Parishad) says: The country where caste rules are not enforced is a barbarian country. (Aspects of Society and Economy of Medieval Mithila – Upendra Thakur)

I have not found any description of the pag prior to Amir Khusrau.

But the pre-Jyotirishvara Vidyapati (author of the Padavali) says:

Nṛpa ithi kāhu karathi nahi sāti

Purakha mahata saba hamara sajāti

Thus, the king punishes no one. And all the great men are of one kin.

Govindadas's verses were complex and lacked such a parallel tradition (likely due to circulation only among the upper castes), which is why they could not be preserved in the soil as Bidapat Nach was. The Tattvachintamani of Gangesh Upadhyaya is discussed, but where are the poems of Vardhamana, who calls him sukavikairava kānānenduḥ (the moon in the lotus grove of fine poets)? Those who were partisan imposed restrictions on writing, but Raghunath Shiromani and his disciples memorized the works of Udayana and Gangesh and carried on, and with the establishment of the Navya-Nyaya school in Navadvipa, the influx of students from Bengal ceased.

(Medieval Mithila, Vijay Kumar Thakur)

Jyotirishvara (1275-1350) Sixth Kallola – "Atha Vidyāvanta Varṇanā": Vidāñota āsthāna bhītara bhaū. Takā pachā telangī. marahaṭhī. vi.daotinī dui citrakaī gānga jauna nihāli aisani deṣuaha. cuañcari cirī ekahoṅka parihane .....se kaisana deṣu. jaise prayāgakṣetra sarasvatīkeṅ gaṅgājamunāka samvāhi. kā ho taise tā vidāñotake duao samvāhikā ho bhaūaha. daśañundhī rājā avadhāna karāu. vidāñota āsthāna vaisu.

(Vidāñota (the male performer) entered; after him, Telangi, Marathi. The female performers (vidaotinī) appeared as if bathing in the two-colored Ganga and Yamuna. They wore a single cloth with four hems. How did they appear? Just as in Prayag, Sarasvati unites with the Ganga and Yamuna, so did both unite with Vidāñota. The king paid attention; Vidāñota sat in the assembly.)

Eighth Kallola – "Atha Rājya Varṇanā": Vidāñota ta.nhika gīta. nṛtya. vādya. tāla. ghāghara pariṭharaiteṁ āha...

There were songs, dances, instruments, rhythms, and the performers wore ghaghra skirts.

Ugna Mahadev: Mahadeva (in the form of Ugna) would disguise himself as a servant named Ugna to hear Vidyapati's songs at Ahitham. This story of Ugna became famous in connection with both the primal poet of Maithili, Vidyapati (pre-Jyotirishvara), and Vidyapati Thakkura (the author in Sanskrit and Avahattha, courtier of King Shivasimha).

Bodhi Kayastha: In Vidyapati Thakkura's Purusha Pariksha, the story of his attainment of the Ganges is narrated. This story was also in circulation regarding the great poet Vidyapati (the author of the pre-Jyotirishvara Maithili Padavali), and later became associated with Vidyapati Thakkura (the author in Sanskrit and Avahattha) as well.

The Sanskrit literature of Vidyapati Thakkura came to light after the decline of the scholarly tradition in Mithila, and there is no significant mention of Vidyapati Thakkura in Sanskrit literature. The influx of students from Bengal also decreased, and for those who continued to come, the Sanskrit and Avahattha works of Vidyapati Thakkura were part of the contemporary scholarly tradition that was fading away, and it continued to be written, but the pre-Jyotirishvara Padavali had already gained fame. Whether the pag existed during the time of Gonu or Vidyapati is also uncertain, as Amir Khusrau (1253-1325) is the only one who mentions it. Vijay Kumar Thakur considers it a feudal symbol associated with tantric rituals. It may have been worn by subordinate feudal lords after the Muslim invasions, and it also resembles a Muslim cap. Only Brahmins and Kayasthas were feudal lords in Mithila after the Muslim invasions (not Rajputs), and even today, it is used among these two classes in certain rituals like black marriages.

Great poet Vidyapati—prior to the poet-king Jyotirishvara (c. 1275-1350) (because Jyotirishvara's works mention him), is the primal poet of Maithili. Distinct from Vidyapati Thakkura of Sanskrit and Avahattha. Possibly the son of Shri Mahesh Thakur of the Naua Thakur caste from Vishfi village (according to tradition). In the Bidapat Nach of the parallel tradition, the Vidyapati Padavali (from the pre-Jyotirishvara era) is performed through dance and drama.

Phanishwar Nath Renu wrote a reportage on Bidapat Nach, which was published in the weekly Vishvamitra on August 1, 1945 AD. This reportage is significant because it was written 700 years after Jyotirishvara's account on this subject, and during those 700 years, the parallel tradition kept Vidyapati alive. And those who kept it alive had Vidyapati unwittingly taken from them. Bideshwar Thakur, while singing Vidyapati's songs and crying out in anguish, met his death when the Brahmins took Vidyapati away by placing a pag on him. Kanungo Badri Prasad Thakur of Brahmapura, Binod Thakur of Pokharibhinda, Saryug Thakur of Rudrapur, Jairam Thakur of Menhath, and the people of Sonse village near Vishfi still chant this lament. Shaligram Yadav and Avadhia Thakur are witnesses to the tradition of Vishfi village. In the ritualistic appropriation of Vidyapati, all sorts of baseless arguments about his birth and origins have been presented, but no research paper has even discussed his parallel tradition. This article is dedicated to thousands of people of the parallel tradition like Bideshwar Thakur who kept Vidyapati alive between the accounts of Jyotirishvara and Phanishwar Nath Renu.

## The Tradition of Mithila's Shatapatha Brahmana and Mithila's Parallel Tradition

Language must have existed even before the Rigveda, the most ancient text of Vedic Sanskrit. Many oral literatures, such as gāthā (songs), nārāshaṃsī (heroic ballads), daivata kathā (divine tales), and ākhyāna (narratives), were composed within it. Terms like gāthin (singer), gātuvid (knower of songs), and gāthapati (master of songs) are used in the Rigveda for such singers. From the Vedic period onward, gāthā and nārāshaṃsī existed in parallel forms.

Did Prakrit emerge from Vedic Sanskrit, or Vedic Sanskrit from Prakrit? The folk narratives called nārāshaṃsī in the Vedas prove that both continued in parallel for a long time. This parallel tradition influenced both. Now consider the Rigveda—what does the use of durlabha for dūlabha (Rigveda 4.9.8) signify? What does paścāt for paścā (Atharvaveda 10.4.10) signify? What does pratisaṃdhāya for pratisaṃhāya (Gopatha Brahmana 2.4) signify?

The Aryas came to Mithila from the western part of India, and before their settlement, some parts of the Vedas were already extant. That is why many words and many pronunciations found in Maithili are present in Vedic Sanskrit but not in Classical Sanskrit. Concepts such as avidyā (ignorance), the doctrine of karma, the cycle of birth and rebirth, and mokṣa (liberation) were transmitted to the Aryans from non-Aryans. Hence, the Upanishads speak of the path to mokṣa, not to heaven. How is mokṣa attained? Through sacrifices? No, it is attained through knowledge, reflection, contemplation, and meditation. Under the patronage of King Janaka, Yajnavalkya composed the Brihadaranyaka Upanishad in the non-Aryan region of Tirhut.

Vachaspati Mishra, while commenting on the Sāṃkhya Kārikā, says: Can one say that the unconscious milk nourishes the calf, and through the operation of the unconscious Prakriti, the soul attains knowledge of liberation? If God is complete in Himself, for what purpose would He create the universe? And if He creates for the sake of souls, then souls would only be created after creation; before creation, there is no question of their being bound. So, where is the question of compassion for souls? Thus, creation occurs through Prakriti, and the soul attains liberation through its own efforts. Dissolution occurs through discrimination. This is not theism but atheism in Vachaspati's interpretation. If God participates in the operation of Prakriti, it would be a conscious process undertaken with some purpose, and such a purpose cannot be ascribed to God. Gautama of Mithila, the author of the Nyāya Sūtras, discusses the attainment of the highest good for the soul through knowledge of sixteen categories, but there is no mention of God as the means of liberation. The Vaiśeṣika Sūtras state that the Vedas were composed by learned men, not by God. Kumarila Bhatta says that any discussion of God prior to creation is impossible to verify.

The so-called mainstream of the Shatapatha Brahmana and its parallel mainstream: Brahminism and non-Brahminism have existed in Mithila from the very beginning. Jyotirishvara writes: The Buddhist path is fearsome in appearance. Due to the seeming similarity with the stagnant Shatapatha Brahmana tradition, there is an obstacle to venerating the Sanskrit and Avahattha Vidyapati. The ṛk and the nārāshaṃsī, the great poet Vidyapati and the Vidyapati of the pag, mokṣa and heaven-hell—these two opposing ideologies have coexisted in Mithila.

The Videgha Mathava of the Shatapatha Brahmana and the Nimi of the Puranas both have the same priest, Gautama, so they are one, and from this, the Videha kingdom began. Mathava's priest Gautama initiated the mitravinda sacrifice/offering, and it was re-established during the time of Mahajanaka II by Yajnavalkya. By constantly invoking Maitreyi, Yajnavalkya, Sita, and Janaka, this tradition quickly carried out Vidyapati's sacred thread ceremony and pag installation, which aligned with the so-called mainstream of the Shatapatha Brahmana.

After the order of the Shakha Panji in 1760 AD by Madhav Singh, neo-élitism spread among Brahmins and Kayasthas in Mithila, leading to the emergence of the Battisgamiya sub-caste among the Karn Kayasthas and the Shrotriya sub-caste among Maithil Brahmins. Physical and mental illnesses increased severely within these two sub-castes, along with a dramatic rise in polygamy, child marriage, and the number of widows. The peaceful and rapid manner in which this occurred was in keeping with the so-called mainstream of the Shatapatha Brahmana.

## Views on Vidyapati by Dineshwar Lal Anand and Ramvriksh Benipuri

Dineshwar Lal Anand was under a misconception. At that time, the Panji was a secret document. The Sanskrit and Avahattha Vidyapati, belonging to Vishfe village, had been recorded in the Panji under the Jayavar (lowest category) section. The Shakha Panji did not exist before 1760 AD, as evidenced by the fact that the descendants of Ayachi Mishra's original lineage are found both in the Shrotriya sub-caste and in the broader Brahmin sub-caste. It is akin to the existence of buffaloes in the Indus Valley civilization (on seals), but not cows—how could buffaloes exist without cows? Anand did not have access to all the facts of the Panji. Propaganda conflating the Vidyapati of the Padavali with the Sanskrit and Avahattha Vidyapati likely led him to believe that if the Vishfe resident could be linked to the Jayavar status in the Panji for writing in Avahattha, then Vidyapati Thakkura's revolutionary nature could be explained. However, Anand himself admits that there is no record—let alone in his own

handwriting—of the Padavali from Vidyapati's time. But how is that possible when the Sanskrit and Avahattha Vidyapati begins and ends all his Sanskrit and Avahattha works with declarations, mentioning which king or queen inspired him, who his patrons were, all in a fully authorial style, boasting of both Saraswati and Lakshmi? Why would he not do the same in the Padavali? Anand is perplexed. The Sanskrit and Avahattha Vidyapati wrote about his patrons, but in no Sanskrit or Avahattha work did he write anything about himself. He experienced pressure to write in Avahattha, which was the literary language of the mainstream at the time. But the influence of the pre-Jyotirishvara Vidyapati was so profound that the Sanskrit and Avahattha Vidyapati was compelled to include Maithili songs in his Sanskrit play Goraksha Vijaya (just as Jyotirishvara, the first to report on Vidāñota, was compelled to include Maithili songs in his Sanskrit play Dhurtasamagama).

Govind Jha recognizes the tradition of Vidyapati in Jyotirishvara's Vidāñota and discusses it, but why does he not advance the case for a pre-Jyotirishvara Vidyapati, especially when Bideshwar Thakur gave up his life singing? When a thirst for Vidyapati arises in a Vidyapati play, how does the playwright's village become involved? Everyone is writing plays about "our Vidyapati" according to their own understanding.

Ramvriksh Benipuri also did not have access to the Panji facts. Based on the fabrication of a sub-caste and legend, he writes humorously about Keshav Mishra and Vidyapati. This Keshav Mishra of the Dvaita appendix is the grandson of Vachaspati II (1400-1490). There is another Keshav Mishra (c. 1150) who wrote Tarkabhāṣā, which was critiqued by Vardhamana, son of the Tattvachintamani author Gangesh, in Tarkaprakāśa. Benipuri could not advance a single step beyond the research conducted by Ananda Coomaraswamy in 1915 AD, nor could any other mainstream researcher in the hundred years since Coomaraswamy. Benipuri narrates the story of Ugna, but he is unclear whether Mahadeva danced on the Śaivasarvvasvasaara of the orthodox Sanskrit and Avahattha Vidyapati in Kailash, or on the dance floor of the pre-Jyotirishvara Vidyapati. Like Coomaraswamy, Benipuri was aware that a manuscript of the Bhagavata in the hand of the Sanskrit and Avahattha Vidyapati exists, and also that Vidyapati attained the Ganges, with the Ganges merging him into herself. Like Coomaraswamy, Benipuri had heard of the Purusha Pariksha written by the Sanskrit and Avahattha Vidyapati but had not read it; otherwise, he would have understood that the Sanskrit and Avahattha Vidyapati wrote the story of

the attainment of the Ganges in relation to Bodhi Kayastha. This story, along with the Ugna story, was prevalent regarding the pre-Jyotirishvara Vidyapati and was later ritually attached to the Sanskrit and Avahattha Vidyapati, with the Bodhi Kayastha story in Purusha Pariksha being evidence of this. Benipuri calls Kirtipataka a collection of Maithili songs!! Is research conducted through inquiry? Why has the mainstream, which dried up after the foundation laid by Coomaraswamy a hundred years ago, not advanced? Because this Shatapatha Brahmana mainstream does not permit it. Yet, without any evidence, they declare Purāditya, a friend of Shivasimha, a Bhumihar Brahmin, just as Ramanath Jha declared Govindadas (Jha) a Shrotriya (Sukumar Sen finds this laughable), and Ramdev Jha is proven a Brahmin, and Kalidasa is proven a Kayastha by Varmaji (in the Laldas souvenir).

The Sanskrit and Avahattha Vidyapati begins and ends his books with full ritualistic pomp, mentioning kings, queens, and patrons, but does not mention himself. Why did the Padavali survive in the mouths of the people, and why was it not given the same treatment of bookish pomp? Because it was composed centuries before him, at a time when the pag had not yet originated in Mithila. Names like Rupanarayan, Shivasimha, Lakhima, Deva Simha, Hara Simha, Padma Simha, Vishvas Deva, Arjuna-Amar, Raghava Simha, Rudra Simha, Dhira Simha, Bhairava Simha, Chandra Simha, etc., were inserted into the Padavali at a later date, which is clearly discernible as it affects the rhythm of the songs. The Sanskrit-Avahattha Vidyapati's works—Bhuparikrama (Deva Simha), Kirtilata (Kirti Simha and Vira Simha), Kirtipataka, Goraksha Vijaya (Shiva Simha), Likhanavali (Purāditya), Dānavākyāvalī (Queen Dhiramati)—were clearly royal patronages. Goraksha Vijaya was written for a Bhairava worship ceremony, and like Dhurtasamagama, it contained Maithili songs, which were a result of the profound influence of the pre-Jyotirishvara Vidyapati. If there were no discrepancy in names, Jyotirishvara would have been made into a pre-Jyotirishvara Vidyapati.

## Conclusion

Gangesh, the author of the Tattvachintamani, wrote a work equivalent to 12,000 texts. Professor Dinesh Chandra Bhattacharya writes in his History of Navya-Nyaya in Mithila: "The family which was inferior in social status is now extinct in Mithila... Gangesha's family is completely ignored and we are not expected to know even his father's name." And he states that all this information was provided to him by Prof. R. Jha (Ramanath Jha)!

Now, let us turn to the facts described in the Panji. It is clearly written there that Gangesh, the author of the Tattvachintamani, was born five years after his father's death and that he married a charmakāriṇī (a woman of the leather-worker caste). Why did Ramanath Jha conceal this from Dinesh Chandra Bhattacharya? The story of how a sub-caste transformed him from a fool into a scholar was fabricated, and a conspiracy was hatched to eliminate him.

Vardhamana, Gangesh's son, calls him sukavikairava kānānenduḥ (the moon in the lotus grove of fine poets). The fact that the poetry of a famous scholar like Gangesh is not available today, under whose conspiracy, is evident from the examples given above. Vasudeva Pakshadhara Mishra of Bengal was a classmate of his. He came to Mithila to study, passed the shalaka examination, and received the title Sarvabhauma. Vasudeva memorized Gangesh's Tattvachintamani and Udayana's Nyāyakusumāñjali verses. Pakshadhara and other Mithila teachers did not allow the copying of the Tattvachintamani! Vasudeva's student Raghunath Shiromani defeated his own teacher Pakshadhara Mishra in debate to establish his authority. The Navya-Nyaya school was established in Navadvipa by Vasudeva and Raghunath. With Raghunath, the influx of students from Bengal to Mithila ceased.

Grierson called the Vishfi copperplate grant given to the Sanskrit and Avahattha Vidyapati by Shivasimha a forgery because he was familiar with Vidyapati's Padavali and understood that it would have been impossible for that Vidyapati to receive such a grant. But that copperplate was indeed received by the Sanskrit and Avahattha Vidyapati, and Grierson could not conceive of the distinction between the two. However, Mahamahopadhyaya Haraprasad Shastri understood this and declared the copperplate genuine.

In Shridhar Das's Sadukti Karnamrita, there are songs in praise of the Ganges by the Kaivarta Papiha. There are songs of Radha-Krishna. The court poet of Lakshmana Sena was Dhoyi (a weaver).

Lakhima Thakurani did not write a Padavali; she wrote verses in Sanskrit (Grierson). Shridhar Das's inscription is at Andhara Thadi, and he was a minister of Nanyadeva and Gangadeva. His descendant Amiyakara was contemporary with the Sanskrit and Avahattha Vidyapati. Upendra Thakur considers Gangadeva a Kalachuri. Vijay Kumar Thakur acknowledges the Vidyapati songs in the Sadukti Karnamrita (by Shridhar Das) as praising the Kalachuri Karna. The opinion of Radha Krishna Choudhary differs from this.

Under no circumstances could this Vidyapati be pre-Jyotirishvara.

"Ramacharita"—Vigrahapala III defeated Karna. In this connection, Radha Krishna Choudhary found two Pala inscriptions from Naulagarh, 16 km north of Begusarai. Karna lived in the 11th century.

The Padavali of the pre-Jyotirishvara Vidyapati is famous in Bengal. Jyotirishvara's Dhurtasamagama is famous in South India. After that, the influx of students from Bengal to Mithila ceased, and with it, the outward flow of Mithila's plays and Padavali.

## Appendix A to Annexure 3: Phanishwar Nath Renu – A Folk Song's Vidyapati

### Introduction

While conducting "research" on the great poet Vidyapati, I felt compelled to title a chapter: "Vidyapati, the Poet of Plowmen, Sowers, and Cart-Drovers." Because in the regions of Purnia and Saharsa, even today, there are troupes that perform dance-dramas, singing Vidyapati's Padavali with deep emotion. The leaders of these troupes are often mahouts, cowherds, and cart-drovers. When I

asked Maithil scholars about this, they retorted, "What delusion have you fallen into? It is because of these ignorant people that Vidyapati's reputation is suffering today. When such ordinary people took a liking to him, they added 'four verses' to Vidyapati's name… You are misguided." Paying no heed to the prohibitions of Mithila's scholars, I happily began preparations to travel to Saharsa (or Saharsha?). Kanchira is a village that falls under the jurisdiction of two district magistrates—half in Saharsa, half in Purnia.

The Vidyapati troupe of Kanchira is recognized in both districts. The day I arrived in Kanchira, a startling event had occurred. The local leader, who had represented the area for ten years, had lost the election. That night, fearing that the dance and song might be misinterpreted, Janak Das, the leader of the "Vidyapati troupe," refused permission for the performance. After much cajoling the next night, he relented. Following considerable argument, the leader Janak Das, circling around, repeated again and again: the "Vidyapati dance" was first born in his family. He would not say anything further. And when he was assured that I had not come to embezzle one or two thousand rupees from the government treasury under the name of the "Vidyapati dance troupe," he struck the mridangam. I watched the dance all night. The cowherd boys, clad in saris, transformed into the pining Radha and began to sing, "How many days will you keep me waiting, O Lord, for I am a woman alone?"

The next day, when I asked Janak Das about the history of this dance, he replied that he did not know—it was just that the roots of this dance had been in his family for generations. Janak Das's sorrow was my tape recorder… I secretly recorded all the songs. "You have done your work cleverly during this time of festive engagement, haven't you?" And in the end, even after giving him fifty rupees in cash, he gave no answer to my question: when, and how, did plowmen, sowers, cowherds, and cart-drovers begin to sing and dance to Vidyapati's Padavali? Janak Das was preoccupied with his buffaloes all day; he felt no pity for me. Even when his young, frail daughter pleaded with me, he did not relent: "You want to 'print' in the 'gazette' the stories that are the family's jest?" The old man left to let his buffaloes graze. I lay by his buffalo shed, and then I heard a tale—or perhaps I dreamt it, or fell into an illusion—I cannot say.

Appendix **B** to Annexure 3: Bidapat Nach (Original Reportage by Phanishwar Nath Renu)

Bidapat Nach

It is assumed that this dance originated in Darbhanga district. But in our own homeland, I need not comment on its current state. However, in some northern Bihar districts, as well as in villages of Bhagalpur, Purnia, and others, it is still valued today. It has become the dance of the common people. The so-called respectable society considers it beneath their dignity to watch it. But among Musahars, Dhangars, Dusadhs, at weddings, tonsure ceremonies, and other occasions, it is a vibrant affair. Seven or eight artists perform in this dance, with only two instruments—the mridangam and the manjira.

So, let's go. Let us enjoy the Bidapat Nach. Set aside your respectability for a while…

Dhrunga dha, dhrunga dha tinna—the mridangam begins to thunder. Kun kun kun kun… the manjira joins in.

Ganānāyakaṃ phaladāyakaṃ paṇḍitam patitam… Do not laugh, everyone. This was the auspicious invocation, in pure Sanskrit.

Dhrungā dhrungā dhrungā dhrungā—the mridangam plays.

Kinkā, kinkā, kinkā, kinkā… the manjira accompanies.

The dancer begins to spin among the spectators gathered all around. The vipata (the female impersonator) also spins like a top, his face painted in various colors, making sounds oye-oye-oye-oye.

Dhirināngī, dhirināngī, dhirināngī, dhirināngī—the mridangam changes rhythm. Kinkā, kinkā… Enough now. We have danced enough… now the story of the dance will follow.

The dancers gather at one spot and sway. Dhirināngi tinatā, titak-titak dhā, titakala gadagina dhā.

The rhythm concludes, and the dance ends; the dancers wipe their sweat and sit among the audience. The vipata who was in the dance glances at the performer. Dhrungā-dhrungā…

Dhin-tinaka tinaka, dhin tinaka-tinaka—the mridangam plays.

The dancer matches the rhythm.

He lel parabeśa parama sukumāri

Haṃsa gamana vṛṣabhāna dulāri…

The dancers rise and approach the vipata; overjoyed, the vipata begins to exclaim oye oye oye oye.

Dhin-tinaka tinaka dhin-tinaka tinaka

He! tana mana badana pavana sahajora he

Dāminī ūpara ugalanhi chānā…

The dancers wipe their sweat, revealing their faces (with stubble, unshaven, misshapen faces), and the spectators laugh heartily. The dancer looks down, dancing shyly, shrinking like a bashful vine—whether real or feigned. The vipata tries to attract her attention.

He bihaṃsi uṭhali piū dekhi suhāginī

Lāja badana lela pheri…

The dancer laughs and turns her face away. When she laughs, her teeth, blackened by tobacco, gleam. Please, everyone, be quiet. Yes, yes. This could be Vidyapati's Padavali, but it is Bidapat Nach.

Stop your chatter about New Theaters, Vidyapati, Kanan Bala, Pahari Sanyal. Let us begin the final recitation.

How many times must I explain that this is Bidapat Nach, and the dancer is Tahalu Paswan, whose father was a notorious dacoit. His father was transported to the Andamans. His mother went off with someone else, and he took to dancing. In his youth, this dance was all the rage… it was a sensation. Seeing his demeanor, a hill woman abandoned her settled household and eloped with him in the night.

So, Tahalu Paswan can sing…

Aṅganā āeta jaba rasiyā

Palata calaba hama iṣat haṃsiyā

Kānha jatana bahu karayinha

Dhrunnā dhrungā, tinā-tinnā—the mridangam changes rhythm.

Kinnā- kinnā… the manjira also changes.

Sakhi he…

Sakhi he, ki pūchhasi anubhava mohe…

Janama avadhi hama rūpa nihāralau,

Tabahu na tiripita bhela.

"Hey? Quiet! Quiet!!"—the vipata scolds, silencing him. One of the dancers begins to twist a towel into a whip. The vipata begins to complain that he is being beaten and harassed in the middle of the night. After taking so many beatings from the landlord's shoes, the skin on his back has thickened. He was just trying to quiet him down…

"If you have spent your whole life gazing at someone's beauty…" When he realized it was his own beauty, he happily and proudly took out a small mirror from his pocket and began to look at his face.

The song ended; now it was the vipata's turn.

• "Hey, respected sir (the lead)."

• "Hmm."

• "Now, hear mine."

"Bāpa re!

Bāpa re, kona durgaati nahi bhela

Sāta sāla hama sūda chukāola,

Tabahu urina nahi bhelau.

Kolhuka barada sana khaṭalau rāti-dina

Kāraja baṛhata hi gela

Thārī beca paṭavārīkeṁ deliyanhi,

Loṭā beca caukīdārī.

Bakarī beca sipāhīkeṁ deliyanhi

Phaṭakanātha giradhārī."

Did you understand anything? You are all Phatakanath Girdharis.

Look at the audience; they didn't understand a thing, but they laugh so hard their bellies ache.

Dhrungā-dhrungā, dhidhinnā tinnā…

"Sakhi he!

Ī māha bhādara, bharala bādara,

Śūnya mandira mora."

Beautiful! Beautiful! Indeed, Vidyapati, the Maithil Kokila…

You've started blundering again; you are no less than the vipata. No matter how much he is told, he has to say something to every song. And here, the vipata has jumped in again…

"Ī māha bhādara, barise bādara,

Cuata chappara mora."

"Haha-haha!!" The audience is rolling with laughter. I almost forgot to mention that the vipata considers himself Krishna, and also the beloved from afar. But he never forgets that he is Kalaru Musahar, a landless laborer, and that as a human being, his status is even lower than that of the oil-press bullock. When the dancers, with arms around his neck, suggest with pride and dignity that Madhava has left for a foreign land, he forgets that he is Krishna leaving Gokul for Mathura. Before him, the harshness of life takes form and dances, and he understands:

Nahiṁ barasala adarā (Ādrā nakṣatra) nahi aśaresa,

Cāru disa dekhaī chī buṛhiyā ke keśa…

Mācha kāchū saba gela pātāla,

Aba ki paḍata sakhi mahā akāla,

Dina bhari khaṭi ke eka sera dhāna,

Ekarā se kaise bacata parāna,

Choḍi- choḍi sajani jāī chī videśa'

The next moment, when the dancer sings:

Godalaya balamakeṁ calali bājāra
Haṭiyā ke loga pūchhe, ke lāge tohāra.
Sāsū jī ke laṛikā, nanada ke jeṭha bhāya,
Pūrva ke likhala svāmī chik he hamāra.

Now the vipata, like a child, begins to whimper for sweets and toys…

Then, one of the dancers sang:

Rāti jakhana bhinasarao re,
Pahū (svāmī) āyala hamāra.
Kara kauśala kara kampaïta re haravā ura jāra
Kara paṅkaja ura thapaïta re mukhacandra nihāra

The vipata stops him in the middle and asks one of the dancers to explain the meaning, and the dancer openly expounds on the song. How the heroine was sleeping on her cot in her hut, and the vipata arrived…

Let us go among the spectators. The young women with dark, plump, firm bodies, suppressing shy smiles, nudging each other and whispering, gaze intently at the vipata. The middle-aged women, feigning modesty, try to restrain the younger ones, but suppressed laughter and fluttering hearts will not obey.

The dancers begin their refrain.

"Calū mana, calū mana… sasurāli
Jaibai ho rāmā,
Ki āho rāmā, naiharā me

Agiyā lagāiba re ki…

The young women become restless, and electricity courses through the young men's bodies. The dance is nearing its end—

"Calū mana, calū mana

Dhin dhinaka dhinaka, dhin dhinaka dhinaka…

Ki āho rāmā, naiharā me agiyā lagāiba re ki…

ḍima ḍimika ḍimika, ḍima ḍimika ḍimika…"

What's this? Oh, it's Chetharu Gusainji! Gusainji is a devotee of Kabir. Ten or fifteen years ago, he refused to give false testimony at the landlord's behest. The landlord, angered, rendered Gusainji homeless, and since then, he has become a wandering ascetic. With his khanjari, jholā, and chimṭā, matted hair, and salt-and-pepper beard… Look, Gusainji is dancing with the dancers, playing his khanjari…

"ḍima ḍimika ḍimika, ḍima ḍimika ḍimika

Ki āho rāmā naiharā me agiyā…"

The thing is, Chetharu Gusainji considers this song to be entirely about the formless divine.

Ah! His sunken eyes sparkle with emotion. And the dance ends.

(This reportage by Phanishwar Nath Renu was published in the weekly "Vishvamitra" on August 1, 1945. This translation from Hindi to Maithili is by

Madhup Nath Jha, published in Videh: Sadeh 11, and is being dedicated to Phanishwar Nath Renu.)

**ANNEXURE: 4**

A Critical Theory for Maithili Original and Translated Dalit Prose-Poetry Literature

Preface: The Necessity of a Critical Theory

A coherent theoretical framework is essential for the literary criticism of any language. In the history of Maithili literary criticism, the influence of both traditional Indian theories (Rasa, Alankara, Dhvani, Riti, Aucitya) and modern Western theories (Marxism, Feminism, Postmodernism, Postcolonialism) is evident. However, attempts to employ these theories in an integrated manner have been limited, particularly in the domains of Dalit literature, women's literature, and translated literature.

The objective of the present critical theory is to establish a systematic framework for evaluating Maithili original and translated prose and poetry by synthesizing Indian and Western literary theories. This theory is neither entirely Indian nor entirely Western; it is a third path forged from the dialogue between the two—a path that centers the specificities of Maithili literature (its language, culture, regional identity) while engaging with global theoretical developments.

## Chapter One: Foundational Elements of the Critical Theory

### 1.1 The Synthesis of Locality and Universality

The primary challenge for any critical theory is to honor the distinctiveness of local (Maithili) literature while fostering a dialogue with universal (Indian or global) literary standards. The distinctiveness of Maithili literature lies in:

The Identity of a Regional Language: Maithili is one of the twenty-nine official languages of India, possessing its own thousand-year-old literary tradition (from Vidyapati to the present).

The Confluence of Folk and Classical Traditions: Maithili literature is deeply infused with folk traditions such as Bidapat Naach, Sohar, Samdauni, and Pagari.

The Experience of Migration: The displacement (migration) of Maithili speakers is a central theme in Dalit literature, women's literature, and translated literature.

Centering these specificities, this critical theory emphasizes a local-universal dialogue. That is, while Indian theories (Rasa, Dhvani, Vakrokti) and Western theories (Postcolonialism, Feminism, Postmodernism) will be employed to evaluate Maithili literature, they will be applied under the purview of Maithili literature's local context.

### 1.2 The Equality and Difference between Original and Translated Literature

This critical theory does not accept any hierarchy between original and translated literature. Both hold equal importance, because:

Maithili translation literature (such as the translations of Telugu, Gujarati, and Odia Dalit literature in the present anthology) expands the scope of Maithili literature.

Translation grants a space within Maithili literature for the voice of the other —an essential requirement for the multilingual character of Indian literature.

However, evaluating translation requires translation-specific criteria: moving beyond the old debate of fidelity versus liberty, and focusing instead on the translation's creativity.

### 1.3 The Distinction between Prose and Poetry

This critical theory acknowledges a clear distinction between prose and poetry:

For poetry, Indian theories—Rasa, Dhvani, Alankara, Chhand (metre)—are more useful, owing to poetry's conciseness, rhythm, and symbolism.

For prose (short stories, novels, plays, essays), Western theories—Marxism, Feminism, Postcolonialism—are more applicable, as prose relies more heavily on elaboration, character development, and socio-political context.

This division, however, is not absolute; the critic may judiciously combine both.

## Chapter Two: The Application of Indian Theories

### 2.1 The Rasa Theory

The Rasa theory is the cornerstone of Indian poetics. In this critical theory, Rasa is applied in the following ways:

a. The Nine Forms of Rasa: While the classical nine rasas (Śṛṅgāra, Hāsya, Karuṇa, Raudra, Vīra, Bhavānaka, Vībhatsa, Adbhuta, Śānta) are present in Maithili literature, their nature is distinct. For instance, the substrate (Āśraya) of Raudra (Fury) in Dalit literature is not a king or warrior but the Dalit community; the determinants (Vibhāva) of Śṛṅgāra (Eros) are not lovers but labor and the body.

b. Expansion of Enduring Moods (Sthāyī Bhāva): This critical theory acknowledges nine new enduring moods: Shrama (Labor), Abhāva (Deprivation), Pratirodh (Resistance), Asmitā (Identity), Pravās (Migration). These are distinctive experiences in Maithili literature, and they can culminate in Rasa.

c. Reconsidering Universalization (Sādhāraṇīkaraṇa): Classical Rasa theory emphasizes universalization. However, in Dalit literature, women's literature, and diasporic literature, it is necessary to honor particularity. To resolve the tension between universalization and particularity, this theory proposes the concept of the particular-universal. That is, not presenting the particular experience as universal, but rather establishing the universal significance of the particular.

2.2 The Dhvani Theory (Ānandavardhana)

The Dhvani theory emphasizes suggested meaning (Vyañjanā). In Maithili literary criticism, Dhvani is applied in the following ways:

a. Levels of Suggestion (Vyañjanā): Maithili poetry (from Vidyapati to the present) relies heavily on suggestion. The critic must distinguish between literal meaning (Abhidhā), metaphorical meaning (Lakṣaṇā), and suggested meaning (Vyañjanā).

b. Dhvani and Translation: Translating suggestion is the greatest challenge in translated literature. This critical theory posits that a translation should strive to preserve the original's suggestion as much as possible; where this is not feasible, creative translation should be accepted.

### 2.3 The Alankara Theory

Alankaras (figures of speech like simile, metaphor, etc.) are integral to Indian aesthetics. In this critical theory:

a. The Sociality of Alankara: In Maithili Dalit literature, Alankaras are used not merely for ornamentation but as a tool for resistance. For example, the simile of Maisamma Devi in the poem "The Border of the Sari" functions as a suggestion that subverts the upper-caste Hindu goddess tradition.

b. Folk-Alankara: Maithili literature has a distinct tradition of folk-ornamentation—such as proverbs, idioms, and sayings. It is essential to accord these the same value as classical Alankaras.

### 2.4 The Riti Theory (Vāmana)

The Riti theory emphasizes style. In Maithili literature:

a. The Stylistic Distinctiveness of Maithili: The melodiousness, softness, and fluidity of the Maithili language are stylistic qualities that must be attended to in criticism.

b. Style in Translation: Balancing the source style and the target style is a crucial concern in evaluating translated literature.

## Chapter Three: The Application of Western Theories

### 3.1 Postcolonial Theory

Postcolonial theory (Edward Said, Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak, Homi K. Bhabha, Dipesh Chakrabarty) is highly applicable to the criticism of Maithili literature, because:

a. Colonial Language Policy: Maithili has for centuries been under the influence of colonial languages (Sanskrit, Persian, Urdu, English, Hindi). This critical theory asks: How does Maithili literature confront this colonial pressure? What are the forms of resistance? What are the forms of accommodation?

b. The Voice of the Subaltern: Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's question—"Can the Subaltern Speak?"—is fundamental to the critique of Maithili Dalit literature, women's literature, and diasporic literature. This theory asks: How is the voice of the subaltern (Dalit, woman, migrant, tribal) represented in Maithili literature? Is that voice free from mediation? If not, is that mediation empowerment or reproduction of subordination?

c. Provincialization: Dipesh Chakrabarty's concept of provincializing Europe is relevant to the criticism of Maithili literature. Resisting the tendency to confine Maithili literature to the category of the regional, this critical theory attempts to establish the global significance of Maithili literature.

### 3.2 Feminist Theory

Feminist theory (Virginia Woolf, Simone de Beauvoir, Judith Butler) is essential for analyzing women's experiences, bodies, voices, and resistance in Maithili literature.

a. Analysis of Women's Writing: The presence of women writers in Maithili literature is growing (e.g., Usha Kiran Khan, Subhadra Jha). This critical theory

asks: How does the voice of a woman writer differ from a male writer's depiction of female characters?

b. Politics of the Body: The representation of the female body is a central issue in Maithili literature. With the aid of feminist theory, the critic can analyze whether the female body is an ornament of Śṛṅgāra or a document of labor? Is it an object of desire or a site of resistance?

c. Intersectionality: Dalit feminism (e.g., Shailaja Devi, Bima Bhim) analyzes the double oppression of caste and gender. This critical theory centers intersectionality, that is, viewing women's experiences in Maithili literature through the confluence of caste, class, region, and religion.

### 3.3 Marxist Theory

Marxist theory (Karl Marx, Georg Lukács, Antonio Gramsci) is useful for analyzing class conflict, economic base, and ideology in literature.

a. Class Conflict: The conflicts between landlord-peasant, laborer-owner, and upper-caste-Dalit are central themes in Maithili literature. Marxist theory analyzes the economic base of these conflicts.

b. Hegemony: Gramsci's concept of hegemony is useful for analyzing the cultural forms of upper-caste dominance in Maithili literature. For example, the process of declaring Vidyapati a Brahmin is an act of hegemony.

c. Market-Capitalism: Translated literature, especially translations of Dalit literature, is coming under the pressure of the market and the publishing industry. Marxist critique analyzes this economic-political context.

### 3.4 Postmodernism and Poststructuralism

Postmodernism (Jean-François Lyotard) and Poststructuralism (Jacques Derrida, Michel Foucault) emphasize the instability of concepts such as truth, identity, author, and history.

a. Instability of Identity: The Maithil identity—linguistic, cultural, regional—is not natural but constructed. Postmodern critique analyzes the process of this construction.

b. Death of the Author: Derrida's concept of the death of the author is particularly relevant to the critique of translated literature. In translation, the boundary between original author and translator blurs. This critical theory proposes a reconsideration of the concept of the author in the context of the translation process.

c. Deconstruction of History: Foucault's archaeology of history is useful for the critical re-reading of historiography in Maithili literature. For example, the history of the construction of Vidyapati's caste demands an analysis of the politics of that historiography.

## Chapter Four: The Practical Framework of the Critical Theory

### 4.1 Levels of Critique

This critical theory proposes five levels for the analysis of a literary work:

First Level: Linguistic Analysis

Analysis of the style, rhythm, vocabulary, and grammatical specificities of the Maithili language.

Analysis of the similarities and differences between the source language and the target language in translated literature.

Second Level: Stylistic Analysis

Application of Indian theories: Riti, Alankara, Guṇa (qualities), Doṣa (flaws).

Application of Western theories: style, narrative technique, imagery, symbolism.

Third Level: Rasa-Dhvani Analysis

Identification of the work's enduring mood (Sthāyī Bhāva).

Analysis of determinants (Vibhāva), consequents (Anubhāva), and transitory states (Vyabhicārī Bhāva).

Identification and analysis of the levels of suggestion (Vyañjanā).

Evaluation of the process of Rasa manifestation (Rasa-niṣpatti).

Fourth Level: Socio-Political Analysis

Marxist theory: class conflict, economic base, ideology.

Feminist theory: gender politics, politics of the body, intersectionality.

Postcolonial theory: subaltern voice, provincialization, politics of translation.

Fifth Level: Aesthetic Analysis (Āsvāda)

The experience of the work's aesthetic relish (Āsvāda) from the perspective of the connoisseur (Sahṛdaya).

The tension between distance and proximity.

The ethics of savoring pain.

4.2 Genre-Specific Analysis

a. For Poetry:

Analysis of metre, rhythm, rhyme—with greater application of Indian theories.

Analysis of image, symbol, metaphor—with application of Western theories.

Identification of the levels of suggestion (Dhvani).

b. For Short Stories and Novels:

Narrative technique—omniscient narration, first-person narration, multiple narration.

Character development—round character, flat character, existential character.

Plot—linear, cyclical, fragmented, stream of consciousness.

Time structure—chronological, non-chronological, flashback, foreshadowing.

c. For Drama:

Theatricality—acting, music, dialogue, audience relationship.

Indian Nāṭyaśāstra theories: Vṛtti (styles of presentation), Pravṛtti (regional conventions), Nāyaka-Nāyikā-bheda (classification of heroes and heroines).

Western dramatic theories: Epic Theatre (Brecht), Theatre of the Absurd (Beckett, Ionesco), Feminist Theatre.

d. For Translated Literature:

The level of equivalence between the source language and the target language.

Translation of suggestion: loss or preservation of Dhvani.

Cultural translation: presentation of locality in a global context.

The creativity of the translator: balancing fidelity and liberty.

## 4.3 Specific Categories of Maithili Literature

This critical theory recognizes the following specific categories within Maithili literature:

a. Folk Literature: Genres such as Bidapat Naach, Sohar, Samdauni, Pagari, wedding songs, Chaura-Chauri, Jhumar require the development of a folk aesthetics for their analysis.

b. Dalit Literature: Maithili Dalit literature is relatively new but growing rapidly. Analyzing this literature requires concepts of Dalit aesthetics—Dard

(Pain), Ākroś (Rage), Pratirodh (Resistance), Asmitā (Identity), Sangharsh (Struggle).

c. Women's Literature: Analyzing themes like the female body, home and the world, motherhood, desire, and resistance in Maithili women's literature requires a feminist aesthetics.

d. Diasporic Literature: Analyzing Maithili diasporic literature (written in Delhi, Mumbai, Kolkata, and foreign countries) requires concepts of diasporic aesthetics—multiple identities, hybridity, displacement from roots.

## Chapter Five: Exemplary Application of the Critical Theory

### 5.1 Example: A Critique of the Present Anthology

The analysis of the present anthology (Dalit literature translated into Maithili) proceeds through the following levels:

First Level: Linguistic Analysis

How have the rhythm, vocabulary, and idioms of the original Telugu, Gujarati, and Odia languages been rendered in the Maithili translation?

How has the localization of Urdu words (present in the Telugu Telangana dialect) been handled in the Maithili translation?

Second Level: Stylistic Analysis

How does the use of imagery (e.g., "burning skull," "border of the sari," "Mankenapuvvu") in the poems contribute to the creation of a Dalit aesthetics?

What narrative techniques (realist, symbolic, allegorical) are employed in the stories ("The Crow," "Black Ink")?

Third Level: Rasa-Dhvani Analysis

Identification of the enduring moods (Sthāyī Bhāva) for Raudra (Fury), Vībhatsa (Odium), and Karuṇa (Pathos).

Inversion of Śṛṅgāra (Eros): presentation of the laboring body and the body in deprivation as its determinants.

Levels of suggestion: the suggestion of the "burning skull" (Dalit identity, religious politics, irony of rebirth).

Fourth Level: Socio-Political Analysis

Class conflict: the conflicts of landlord-peasant and capital-labor.

Caste politics: the conflict between upper-caste and Dalit, untouchability, caste violence.

Gender politics: patriarchy, oppression of the female body, the double oppression of Dalit women.

Subaltern voice: representation of marginalized communities like Madiga (leather worker), Bandodu, Kalandar (bear handler).

Fifth Level: Aesthetic Analysis (Āsvāda)

Savoring of Pain: Can a reader savor Dalit pain? If so, what is the ethics of this savoring?

Distance and Proximity: Does the experience of aesthetic relish differ between a Dalit reader and a non-Dalit reader?

Rasa-niṣpatti (Manifestation of Rasa): Does this literature achieve Rasa-niṣpatti, or does it founder on the limits of Rasa?

## Chapter Six: Limitations and Possibilities of the Critical Theory

### 6.1 Limitations

No theory is perfect. This critical theory has the following limitations:

a. Difficulty of Synthesis: The terminology, concepts, and philosophies of Indian and Western theories differ. Their synthesis inevitably creates tension. This theory does not seek to suppress that tension but suggests its creative utilization.

b. Diversity of Maithili Literature: Maithili literature, from Vidyapati to the present, is immensely diverse—epics, Padyāvalī (lyrics), folk theatre, modern poetry, novels, short stories, Dalit writing, women's writing, diasporic writing. It would be inappropriate to claim that a single theory can fully explicate all genres. This theory emphasizes flexibility—the critic applies the theory using their own judgment.

c. Specificity of Translation: Critiquing translated literature requires knowledge of both the original and the translation. Not all critics are multilingual. This theory acknowledges the limitations of translation criticism and explores the possibility of collaborative critique.

### 6.2 Possibilities

a. Interdisciplinarity: This critical theory connects literature with history, sociology, political science, philosophy, and linguistics. This interdisciplinary perspective opens up possibilities for a multidimensional analysis of Maithili literature.

b. Comparative Literature: This theory opens avenues for comparative study of Maithili literature with literatures in other Indian languages (Telugu, Gujarati, Odia, Bangla, Hindi) and with global literature.

c. Translation Studies: This theory establishes translation not as secondary but as a creative genre. It opens avenues for the development of translation criticism.

d. Localization of Theory: This theory both accepts and critiques Western theory—employing postcolonial theory while also critiquing its Eurocentric tendencies.

## Conclusion: The Future of the Critical Theory

This critical theory is an attempt at synthesis of Indian and Western theories, but this synthesis is not free from contradiction. This contradiction is not the theory's weakness but its strength—because it acknowledges the complexity of literature, rather than attempting to simplify it.

Maithili literature, with its thousand-year history, its confluence of folk and classical traditions, its experience of migration, and the rise of its Dalit and women's voices, requires a critical theory that centers the local while engaging with the global. This theory is an attempt to answer that necessity.

This theory does not claim to be the final truth; it is a starting point. It opens new doors for Maithili literary criticism—doors where a dialogue between Rasa and Dard, Dhvani and Resistance, Alankara and Hybridity, Śānta (Peace) and Struggle becomes possible.

Final Note from the Critic: A critical theory remains alive only when it continues to evolve, continues to question, and continues to confront new literary experiences. This theory is an invitation to that evolution. The future criticism of Maithili literature will continue to respond to this invitation.

## Appendix: A Concise Outline of the Critical Theory

Level of Analysis Indian Theory Western Theory Maithili Specificity

Linguistic Śabda-śakti (Word-potency), Grammar Stylistics, Linguistics Maithili pronunciation, Idioms

Stylistic Riti, Alankara, Guṇa, Doṣa Narratology, Imagery, Symbolism Folk-ornamentation, Proverbs

Rasa-Dhvani Rasa, Dhvani, Vyañjanā Phenomenology, Hermeneutics Dalit-Rasa, Diaspora-Rasa

Socio-Political – Marxism, Feminism, Postcolonial Caste-Gender-Class-Migration

Aesthetic (Āsvāda) Sahṛdaya, Vyutpatti (Training) Reception Theory, Reader-Response Dalit reader, Non-Dalit reader

This outline provides the critic with flexibility—the freedom to choose levels and theories according to their own judgment.

A Critical Theory for Dalit Literature: A Framework for the Distinctive Critique of Maithili Original and Translated Dalit Prose-Poetry, Based on Indian and Western Literary Theories

Preface: The Distinctive Necessity of Criticism for Dalit Literature

Dalit literature is not merely a literary genre; it is a movement, a manifesto of resistance. It centers pain, rage, identity, and struggle. For this reason, general literary theories are insufficient for the criticism of Dalit literature. There is a need for a specific critical theory—one that acknowledges the particularity of Dalit literature, understands its politics, and fosters a dialogue between its aesthetics and the tradition of Rasa theory.

This theory, by synthesizing Indian (Rasa, Dhvani, Alankara, Riti, Aucitya) and Western (Marxism, Feminism, Postcolonialism, Dalit Movement Theory, Postmodernism) theories, presents a fine-tuned framework for the critique of Maithili original and translated Dalit prose and poetry.

## Chapter One: The Specificity of Dalit Literature—Theoretical Foundations

### 1.1 Foundational Elements of Dalit Aesthetics

The aesthetics of Dalit literature is fundamentally distinct from classical aesthetics. Classical aesthetics (Rasa, Alankara, Dhvani) centers on the aesthetic relish (Āsvāda) of the connoisseur (Sahṛdaya); Dalit aesthetics centers on the authenticity of Dalit experience. This theory acknowledges the following Dalit-specific concepts:

a. Dard (Pain) as an Enduring Mood (Sthāyī Bhāva): In classical Rasa theory, the enduring mood for Karuṇa (Pathos) is Śoka (Grief). In Dalit literature, however, it is not grief but pain—a phenomenon pervasive on physical, mental, social, and historical levels. This theory accepts Dard as an enduring mood and explores the possibility of its manifestation as Rasa.

b. Ākroś (Rage) as an Extension of Raudra: The enduring mood for classical Raudra (Fury) is Krodha (Anger), and its substrate (Āśraya) is the king-warrior (slaying demons and giants). In Dalit literature, the substrate of Ākroś is the Dalit community, and its object is the caste system. This theory accepts Ākroś as an extension (and a new form) of Raudra.

c. Asmitā (Identity) as a New Form of Vīra: The enduring mood for classical Vīra (Heroism) is Utsāha (Enthusiasm), and its substrate is the king-warrior. In Dalit literature, the enthusiasm of Asmitā is the reclamation of Dalit identity. This theory accepts Asmitā as a new form of Vīra.

d. Sangharsh (Struggle) as a New Rasa: Shrama (Labor), Abhāva (Deprivation), Pratirodh (Resistance), Pravās (Migration)—these enduring moods do not fit neatly into any category of classical Rasa. This theory accepts these as new enduring moods and explores the possibility of their manifestation as Rasa (Shrama-Rasa, Abhāva-Rasa, Pratirodh-Rasa, Pravās-Rasa).

### 1.2 The Socio-Political Basis of Dalit Literature

a. Centrality of the Caste System: For the criticism of Dalit literature, the caste system is the central category. While class, gender, and region are important, caste is the primary structure of Dalit literature.

b. The Experience of Untouchability: Untouchability is not merely social but a central element of Dalit experience on mental, physical, and spiritual levels. The criticism of Dalit literature requires the development of an aesthetics of untouchability.

c. The Politics of Exclusion: Dalit literature is a document of exclusion—from education, religion, society, history, and literature. Dalit literary criticism analyzes the structure of this exclusion and the strategies of resistance.

d. The Rewriting of Dalit History: Dalit literature is an attempt to rewrite history—against upper-caste historiography and reconstructing history from a Dalit perspective. Dalit literary criticism analyzes this politics of historiography.

## Chapter Two: Fine-Tuning Indian Theories for Dalit Literature

### 2.1 A Dalit Re-reading of Rasa Theory

a. Proposal of Dard-Rasa (Pain Rasa)

In classical Rasa theory, pain is merely a consequent (Anubhāva) of Karuṇa, not an enduring mood (Sthāyī Bhāva). Drawing from the experience of Dalit literature, this theory proposes Dard as an enduring mood:

Sthāyī Bhāva (Enduring Mood): Dard (Pain)

Vibhāva (Determinants): Caste violence, Untouchability, Hunger, Unemployment, Migration, Exploitation, Humiliation, Exclusion

Anubhāva (Consequents): Tears, Lamentation, Bodily pain, Silence, Anger, Resistance, Isolation, Suicide

Vyabhicārī Bhāva (Transitory States): Despair, Hope, Anger, Fear, Hatred, Shame, Pride, Enthusiasm

Rasa-niṣpatti (Rasa Manifestation): Dard-Rasa

b. Proposal of Ākroś-Rasa (Rage Rasa)

Classical Raudra (Fury) cannot fully account for the Ākroś (Rage) of Dalit literature, because the substrate (Āśraya) of Raudra is the king-warrior, while the substrate of Ākroś is the Dalit community. This theory proposes Ākroś-Rasa:

Sthāyī Bhāva: Ākroś (Rage)

Vibhāva: Caste humiliation, Exploitation, Oppression, Injustice, Historical wrongs

Anubhāva: Shouts, Resistance songs, Struggle movements, Revolutionary writing, Testimonies

Vyabhicārī Bhāva: Anger, Hatred, Enthusiasm, Courage, Fear, Hope, Despair

Rasa-niṣpatti: Ākroś-Rasa

c. Proposal of Asmitā-Rasa (Identity Rasa)

Classical Vīra (Heroism) cannot fully account for the Asmitā (Identity) of Dalit literature, because the substrate of Vīra is the warrior, while the substrate of Asmitā is the Dalit renaissance. This theory proposes Asmitā-Rasa:

Sthāyī Bhāva: Asmitā (Identity)

Vibhāva: Rediscovery of Dalit history, Restoration of Dalit symbols, Reconstruction of Dalit language

Anubhāva: Pride, Self-confidence, Courage, Struggle, Unity, Organization

Vyabhicārī Bhāva: Enthusiasm, Pride, Anger, Hope, Despair, Resolve

Rasa-niṣpatti: Asmitā-Rasa

d. Proposal of Sangharsh-Rasa (Struggle Rasa)

Labor, Deprivation, Resistance, Migration—these are central experiences in Dalit literature. This theory proposes Sangharsh-Rasa:

Sthāyī Bhāva: Sangharsh (Struggle)

Vibhāva: Labor, Deprivation, Resistance, Migration, Livelihood struggle

Anubhāva: Labor songs, Resistance songs, Migration songs, Bodily exhaustion, Tears of struggle

Vyabhicārī Bhāva: Despair, Hope, Anger, Enthusiasm, Fear, Courage

Rasa-niṣpatti: Sangharsh-Rasa

2.2 A Dalit Re-reading of Dhvani Theory

Dhvani theory (Ānandavardhana) emphasizes suggested meaning (Vyañjanā). In Dalit literature, three levels of suggestion are particularly important:

a. First Level of Suggestion: Verbal Suggestion: The gap between a word's literal meaning and its suggested meaning. For example, in the poem "My Ancestral Right," digging up the graveyard—the literal meaning is exhumation, the suggested meaning is the search for right/entitlement.

b. Second Level of Suggestion: Mythological Suggestion: A Dalit perspective re-reading of mythological symbols. For example, in the poem "My Ancestral Right," the mythological characters Vyasa, Arundhati, and Matsyagandhi are reinterpreted from a Dalit perspective.

c. Third Level of Suggestion: Ideological Suggestion: The suggestion made from a Dalit perspective on ideologies like the caste system, religion, politics, and history. For example, in the poem "The Burning Skulls," the concept of reincarnation is used to suggest the establishment of caste violence under the guise of religion.

### 2.3 A Dalit Re-reading of Alankara Theory

In Dalit literature, Alankaras are not merely ornamentation; they are weapons of resistance:

a. Alankara of Inversion: A Dalit inversion of classical Alankaras. For example, the simile of Maisamma Devi in the poem "The Border of the Sari" is an inversion of the Upamā Alankara, where the goddess (the classical ideal) is transformed into the laboring body (Dalit reality).

b. Folk-Alankara: Alongside classical Alankaras (simile, metaphor, etc.), folk-ornamentation—proverbs, idioms, sayings, riddles, folk song figures—must be given equal value. For example, "as immovable as a stone crushed under jaggery" (from the novel Friends Forever) is a folk-Alankara.

c. Alankara of Absence: The use of absence as an ornament. For example, in the poem "People, Burn to Death," emptiness, stone, gravel—these are symbols of absence, used as an Alankara of Absence.

### 2.4 A Dalit Re-reading of Riti Theory

Riti theory (Vāmana) emphasizes style. The stylistic distinctiveness of Dalit literature:

a. Style of Resistance: Contrary to classical mādhurya-guṇa (sweetness) or oja-guṇa (vigor), the style of Dalit literature is sharp, harsh, obscene, rebellious. This style is a Dalit inversion of classical style.

b. Testimonial Style: The style of Dalit literature is a style of testimony—autobiography, narrative of experience, documentary narrative. This style erases the boundary between the personal and the collective.

c. Folk Style: The style of Dalit literature is deeply connected to folk language, folk songs, folk tales, and folk theatre. This folk style is a Dalit resistance to classical style.

## Chapter Three: Fine-Tuning Western Theories for Dalit Literature

### 3.1 A Dalit Re-reading of Postcolonial Theory

a. A Dalit Re-reading of the Subaltern: Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's question—"Can the Subaltern Speak?"—is fundamental to the criticism of Dalit literature. Dalit literature reveals the tension between the subaltern (a category of postcolonial theory) and the Dalit (a category of the Indian caste system). This theory asks: Is the subaltern voice in Dalit literature free from mediation? If not, is that mediation empowerment or reproduction?

b. A Dalit Re-reading of Provincialization: Dipesh Chakrabarty's concept of provincializing Europe is relevant to the criticism of Dalit literature. Dalit literature is an attempt to provincialize upper-caste literature—which claims universality but is in fact caste-specific. Dalit literary criticism deconstructs this claim to universality.

c. A Dalit Re-reading of Hybridity: Homi K. Bhabha's concept of hybridity is useful for analyzing the identity politics of Dalit literature. Dalit literature occupies a hybrid space between upper-caste culture and Dalit culture—neither fully assimilated into the former, nor fully liberated from it. This hybridity is a source of tension and creativity in Dalit literature.

### 3.2 The Application of Dalit Feminist Theory

a. Intersectionality: Dalit feminism (e.g., Shailaja Devi, Bima Bhim, J. Subhadra, Vinodini) analyzes the double oppression of caste and gender. For the criticism of Dalit literature, intersectionality is a central category—analyzing Dalit women's experiences at the confluence of caste, gender, class, region, and religion.

b. Politics of the Body: The Dalit woman's body is not an ornament of classical Śṛṅgāra but a document of labor. Dalit literary criticism analyzes the politics of the body—how the body becomes a mark of the caste system; how the body becomes a site of resistance.

c. Dalit Women's Voice: The Dalit woman's voice occupies a third space between the Dalit male voice and the upper-caste female voice—distinct from both. Dalit literary criticism analyzes the particularity of this third space.

### 3.3 A Dalit Re-reading of Marxist Theory

a. Class and Caste Conflict: Marxist theory emphasizes class struggle. Dalit literature presents class struggle in the form of caste struggle. Dalit literary criticism analyzes the dialogue and tension between class and caste.

b. A Dalit Re-reading of Hegemony: Gramsci's concept of hegemony is useful for analyzing the cultural forms of upper-caste dominance in Dalit literature. For example, the process of declaring Vidyapati a Brahmin is a cultural act of hegemony. Dalit literature is written against that hegemony.

c. A Dalit Critique of Market-Capitalism: A critique of the politics of the publishing industry, market, and awards in Dalit literature is necessary. Marxist critique asks: Is Dalit literature losing its creativity under market pressure? Are awards a form of empowerment or co-optation?

### 3.4 Dalit Movement Theory

a. The Tradition of Jyotirao Phule's Gulamgiri (Slavery): Phule's Gulamgiri (1873) is a foundational text of Dalit literature. Dalit literary criticism analyzes the continuity and change from Gulamgiri to contemporary Dalit literature.

b. Dr. B. R. Ambedkar's Intellectual Tradition: Ambedkar's intellectual tradition —Annihilation of Caste, Buddhist conversion, constitution-making—forms the ideological foundation of Dalit literature. Dalit literary criticism analyzes the literary forms of this intellectual tradition.

c. The Resistance Literature of the Dalit Panthers: The Dalit Panther movement of the 1970s played a foundational role in the formation of the rage style of Dalit literature. Dalit literary criticism analyzes the continuity and rupture from the Dalit Panthers to contemporary Dalit literature.

## Chapter Four: A Practical Framework for the Criticism of Dalit Literature

### 4.1 Levels of Critique for Dalit Literature

First Level: Caste Analysis

Identification of the work's caste structure: What are the characters' castes? How does the plot represent caste relations? How does the author's caste position determine the work's perspective?

Analysis of the aesthetics of untouchability, caste violence, and caste discrimination.

Second Level: Analysis of Dalit Aesthetics

Analysis of the manifestation as Rasa of the enduring moods: Dard (Pain), Ākroś (Rage), Asmitā (Identity), Sangharsh (Struggle).

Analysis of the style of resistance, testimonial style, and folk style.

Analysis of the Alankara of Inversion, Alankara of Absence, and Folk-Alankara.

Third Level: Socio-Political Analysis

Caste politics: Upper-caste-Dalit conflict, reservation, political representation, Dalit movements.

Class politics: Landlord-peasant conflict, capital-labor conflict, economic exploitation.

Gender politics: Double oppression of Dalit women, politics of the body, Dalit feminism.

Migration politics: Economics of migration, psychology of migration, identity in migration.

Fourth Level: Historical-Archival Analysis

Analysis of the process of rewriting Dalit history.

Deconstruction of upper-caste historiography.

Reconstruction of silent history—the rereading of folk history, oral history, and Dalit history absent from written history.

Fifth Level: Analysis of the Politics of Aesthetic Experience (Āsvāda)

Does the experience of aesthetic relish (Āsvāda) differ between a Dalit reader and a non-Dalit reader?

What is the ethics of savoring pain? Does the aestheticization of suffering lead to the reproduction of oppression?

How should the concept of the connoisseur (Sahṛdaya) be redefined in the Dalit context?

## 4.2 Genre-Specific Analysis of Dalit Literature

a. For Dalit Poetry:

Analysis of metre-rhythm: Are traditional metres (e.g., Doha, Chaupai, Soratha) used, or free verse?

Analysis of image-symbol: How do Dalit images (e.g., "burning skull," "border of the sari," "Mankenapuvvu," "black ink") become symbols of resistance?

Analysis of suggestion: How is the Dalit perspective established in the gap between a poem's literal meaning and its suggested meaning?

b. For Dalit Short Stories and Novels:

Narrative technique: First-person narrative and testimonial style are particularly important in Dalit literature, as they claim authenticity.

Character development: Analysis of the psychology of Dalit characters, the representation of upper-caste characters, and how character relationships reproduce or resist the caste system.

Politics of space-time: How do spaces—village, city, forest, hut, palace, police station—reflect the geographical structure of the caste system?

c. For Dalit Drama:

Theatricality: The connection of Dalit drama to traditions like Bidapat Naach, Jatra, Tamasha, and folk theatre.

Acting-music-dialogue: How do body, voice, and rhythm become weapons of resistance in Dalit drama?

Audience relationship: Dalit drama makes the audience a participant, not merely a sympathizer. Analysis of this audience relationship.

d. For Translated Dalit Literature:

Translator's creativity: How is the Dalit voice of the source language established in the target language?

Cultural translation: How are cultural categories like the caste system, Dalit experience, and traditions of resistance localized in the translation process?

Politics of Dalit translation: Is translation of Dalit literature an expansion of the Dalit voice or a distortion? Does translation bring Dalit literature to a global reader or become a tool for co-optation into mainstream literature?

## Chapter Five: Exemplary Application of the Critical Theory for Dalit Literature

### 5.1 A Critique of the Present Anthology (Dalit Literature Translated into Maithili)

#### First Level: Caste Analysis

The central theme of the anthology is the caste system—caste violence, untouchability, Dalit resistance, Dalit identity.

Character caste: Dalit characters: Vyasa, Arundhati, Matsyagandhi (mythological Dalits) in Boyi Bhimanna's poem; J. Subhadra's Dalit women laborers; Kolakaluri Enoch's Bandodu (Madiga); Peddinti Ashok Kumar's Imam (Kalandar).

Upper-caste characters: Landlord, Patel, MRO, SI, Sarpanch, Bachchi Shriya (who becomes anti-Dalit).

#### Second Level: Analysis of Dalit Aesthetics

Enduring moods: Dard (J. Subhadra's "Loadab," "Avva"), Ākroś (Boyi Bhimanna's "My Ancestral Right"), Asmitā (Challapalli Swaruparani's "Mankenapuvvu"), Sangharsh (Kolakaluri Enoch's "The Crow," Peddinti Ashok Kumar's Friends Forever).

Rasa manifestation: Dard-Rasa, Ākroś-Rasa, Asmitā-Rasa, Sangharsh-Rasa.

Style of resistance: Sharp, harsh, rebellious language; testimonial style: first-person narrative, autobiographical style; folk style: use of proverbs, idioms, folk songs.

#### Third Level: Socio-Political Analysis

Caste politics: Upper-caste-Dalit conflict, caste violence, untouchability, psychology of the caste system.

Class politics: Landlord-peasant conflict, capital-labor conflict, economic exploitation.

Gender politics: Double oppression of Dalit women, politics of the body, Dalit feminist voice.

Migration politics: The economics and psychology of migration in the novel Friends Forever.

Fourth Level: Historical-Archival Analysis

Dalit re-reading of mythological history: Boyi Bhimanna's reinterpretation of Vyasa, Arundhati, Matsyagandhi.

Dalit re-reading of medieval history: Re-reading of historical documents on the caste system and Dalit resistance.

Dalit re-reading of modern history: Representation of Gandhi, Ambedkar, and Dalit movements (satire on Gandhi in the Gujarati poem "The Sticks of Khardar").

Fifth Level: Analysis of the Politics of Aesthetic Experience (Āsvāda)

Dalit reader: The anthology offers the savoring of identity—a literary expression of one's own pain.

Non-Dalit reader: The anthology offers an experience of discomfort and awakening—an opportunity to become a witness to another's pain.

Ethics of savoring pain: The anthology does not aestheticize pain; it documents pain. This documentation makes the reader a witness to pain, not a consumer.

## Chapter Six: Limitations and Possibilities of the Critical Theory for Dalit Literature

### 6.1 Limitations

a. Difficulty of Theoretical Synthesis: The terminology, philosophy, and priorities of Indian (Rasa, Dhvani, Alankara) and Western (Marxism, Feminism, Postcolonial) theories differ. Their synthesis inevitably creates tension. This theory does not suppress that tension but suggests its creative utilization.

b. Internal Diversity of Dalit Literature: Dalit literature is not homogeneous—Dalit poetry, Dalit short story, Dalit novel, Dalit drama, Dalit autobiography, Dalit criticism all have stylistic, structural, and ideological differences. It would be inappropriate to claim that a single theory can fully explicate all genres. This theory emphasizes flexibility—the critic applies the theory using their own judgment.

c. Specificity of Translated Dalit Literature: Critiquing translated Dalit literature requires knowledge of both the source language and the target language. Not all critics are multilingual. This theory acknowledges the limitations of translation criticism and explores the possibility of collaborative critique.

d. Institutional Limitations of Dalit Criticism: Dalit literary criticism is coming under the pressure of academic institutions, the publishing industry, and the award system. These institutional limitations call into question the autonomy of Dalit criticism.

6.2 Possibilities

a. Development of Dalit Aesthetics: This critical theory provides a theoretical foundation for Dalit aesthetics—establishing Dard (Pain), Ākroś (Rage), Asmitā (Identity), and Sangharsh (Struggle) as enduring moods and exploring the possibility of their manifestation as Rasa.

b. Interdisciplinarity: This critical theory connects literature with sociology, history, political science, philosophy, and anthropology. This interdisciplinary

perspective opens up possibilities for a multidimensional analysis of Dalit literature.

c. Comparative Dalit Literature Studies: This theory opens avenues for comparative study of Maithili Dalit literature with Dalit literature in other Indian languages—Telugu, Gujarati, Odia, Tamil, Kannada, Marathi, Hindi, Bangla. This Comparative Dalit Literature Studies analyzes both the unity and diversity of Indian Dalit literature.

d. A Dalit Re-reading of Translation Studies: This theory establishes translation not as secondary but as a creative genre. Dalit Translation Studies analyzes the inter-lingual flow of Dalit literature.

e. Globalization of Dalit Criticism: This theory connects Dalit criticism to global theoretical discourse—establishing a dialogue between Dalit literature and global theoretical currents such as postcolonialism, subaltern studies, intersectionality, politics of pain, and testimonial literature.

## Conclusion: The Future of the Critical Theory for Dalit Literature

Dalit literature is not merely literature; it is a movement, a manifesto of resistance. For this reason, general literary theories are insufficient for its criticism. This critical theory, by achieving a synthesis of Indian (Rasa, Dhvani, Alankara, Riti) and Western (Marxism, Feminism, Postcolonialism, Dalit Movement Theory) theories, centers the particularity of Dalit literature.

This theory does not claim to be the final truth; it is a starting point. It opens new doors for the criticism of Dalit literature—doors where the theoretical legitimacy of Dard-Rasa (Pain Rasa), Ākroś-Rasa (Rage Rasa), Asmitā-Rasa (Identity Rasa), and Sangharsh-Rasa (Struggle Rasa) becomes possible.

The future criticism of Dalit literature will move forward from this starting point—towards the enrichment of Dalit aesthetics, the expansion of Comparative Dalit Literature Studies, the development of Dalit Translation Studies, and the globalization of Dalit criticism.

Appendix: A Concise Outline of the Critical Theory for Dalit Literature

Level of Analysis  Indian Theory (Dalit Re-reading)  Western Theory (Dalit Re-reading)  Dalit Specificity

Caste Analysis – Caste politics, Untouchability, Caste violence  Character caste, Author caste, Plot caste

Dalit Aesthetics  Dard-Rasa, Ākroś-Rasa, Asmitā-Rasa, Sangharsh-Rasa – Alankara of Inversion, Alankara of Absence, Folk-Alankara

Socio-Political – Caste-Class-Gender-Migration Politics  Intersectionality, Dalit Feminism, Subaltern Voice

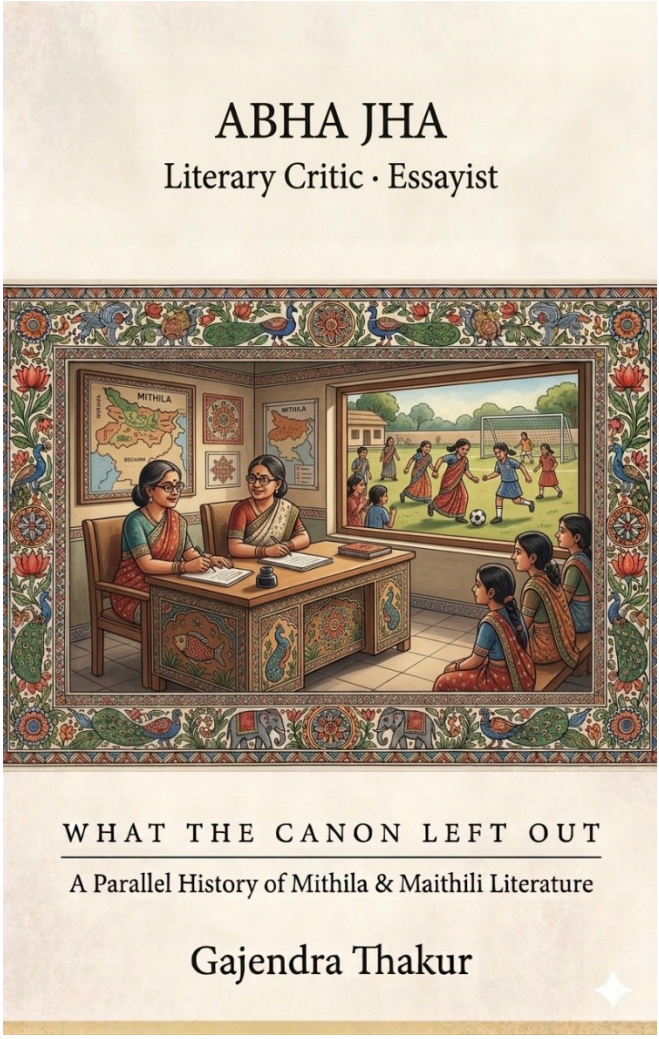
Historical-Archival – Postcolonialism, Archaeology  Rewriting Dalit History, Reconstructing Silent History

Politics of Āsvāda  Sahṛdaya (Dalit Re-reading)  Reception Theory, Reader-Response  Dalit Reader, Non-Dalit Reader, Ethics of Savoring Pain

This outline provides the critic with flexibility—the freedom to choose levels and theories according to their own judgment and to apply them in the specific context of Dalit literature.

The criticism of Dalit literature does not lay claim to theoretical purity; it seeks literary authenticity. This theory is merely a direction for that search. Dalit literature is living, evolving, resisting. Its criticism must also be living, evolving, and resistant. This theory is an invitation to that resistant criticism.

LESSON 007 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY




## ABHA JHA *Literary Critic · Essayist*

### A Note on Archival Honesty

The critical essay 'Daidigam — Madhyamargak Anweshanki Katha' (डैडीगाम — मध्यमार्गक अन्वेषणक कथा), published in Videha Issue 369 (Ashok Visheshshank, 2023), at pages 29–33.

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### Methodological Framework

This critical appreciation applies the four-fold methodology of the Videha Parallel History Series: (1) Indian Rasa-Dhvani-Vakrokti Aesthetics (Bharata, Abhinavagupta, Anandavardhana, Kuntaka, Kshemendra); (2) Western Critical Theory (New Criticism, Feminist Criticism, Postcolonial Theory, Subaltern Studies); (3) Navya-Nyaya Epistemology of Gangesa Upadhyaya (pratyaksha, anumana, upamana, shabda); and (4) the Videha Parallel History Framework. All analysis is grounded in what the archive text actually says.

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## I. Biographical Profile: What the Archive Tells Us

Abha Jha writes fluent, precise Maithili; she commands both Sanskrit literary theory (opening with the maxim 'gadyam kavinam nikasham vadanti') and contemporary critical vocabulary ('madhyamarg', 'aadarshvadi', 'yatharth'); she reads fiction attentively and thematically, moving through fifteen stories of a collection with disciplined analytical care; and she writes with the voice of a 'sampaadhaaranya paathak' — an ordinary reader who is, in fact, an acutely perceptive one. She is a serious literary critic working within the Videha tradition of engaged, socially conscious literary assessment.

Her essay appears at item 2.5 in the Ashok Visheshshank table of contents, alongside contributions from Kalpana Jha (item 2.4), Dilip Kumar Jha (2.6), Ajit Kumar Jha (2.7), Kumar Rahul (2.8), Lal Dev Kamat (2.9), Hitnath Jha (2.10), Shivshankar Srinivas (2.11), Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil' (2.12), Narayanji (2.13), and Gajendra Thakur himself (2.16–2.18). This is the most serious critical company the Videha movement has to offer: her inclusion among them is itself a mark of recognised critical standing.

# II. The Attested Work: 'Daidigam — Madhyamargak Anweshanki Katha'

## 2.1 Context: Ashok Visheshshank (Videha Issue 369, 2023)

Videha Issue 369 is a special issue dedicated entirely to the Maithili writer Ashok (born 18 January 1953, Lohna, Madhubani; retired Bihar Cooperative Service officer). Ashok is one of the most significant fiction writers in the Videha parallel tradition, author of thirteen published books across poetry, fiction, interview-collection, travelogue, criticism, and satire. His story collection Daidigam (2017) — the subject of Abha Jha's essay — contains fifteen stories. The special issue is the ninth in Videha's 'Jeebait Muda Upekshit' (Living But Neglected) series of author-focused issues, which began in 2015. The series explicitly foregrounds authors who are active and significant yet overlooked by the mainstream Sahitya Akademi establishment.

The Visheshshank was compiled and published in 2023, following a public announcement in December 2022. Abha Jha's essay is one of twenty-two critical contributions to the issue — evidence that her critical voice was specifically invited and valued by the Videha editorial team as part of its most sustained institutional project.

## 2.2 The Essay: Structure and Method

Abha Jha's essay opens with a Sanskrit literary axiom: 'Gadyam kavinam nikasham vadanti' — 'Prose is said to be the touchstone of poets.' She uses this classical critical principle to frame her approach to Ashok's fiction: if prose is the truest test of literary ability (because it has none of the structural supports of metre, rhyme, or formal convention), then the quality of Ashok's storytelling must be assessed by the demands of pure prose composition. This opening move is sophisticated — it grounds a contemporary assessment in classical Sanskrit poetics and sets a high evaluative standard from the start.

She then moves to the collection's title story, 'Daidigam' (Father's Village), which concerns a retired migrant worker, Raghuvansh Babu, who returns to his village in the twilight of his life. The story's tension — between the diasporic Maithili's nostalgia for the village and the village's actual changed reality — is, Abha Jha argues, the collection's defining thematic concern. Her phrase 'madhyamargak anweshankatha' (the story of the middle-path search) is the

essay's analytical core: Ashok's fiction consistently seeks a middle ground between nostalgic idealism and unsentimental realism, between the village that memory preserves and the village that contemporary social forces are transforming.

She proceeds through the collection story by story, with sustained critical attention:

**'Daidigam' (title story):**

Raghuvansh Babu and his family return to the village planning to build a temple. A young villager challenges this: hospitals, schools, colleges would serve the community better than another temple. Abha Jha reads this moment as Ashok's way of 'indirectly expressing his own view, reminding the wealthy diaspora of their duty.' She notes both the story's optimism (all characters, including family and community, arrive at understanding) and its implicit social critique of the 'feudal tendency of the wealthy' whose sense of the village's horizon remains narrow.

**'Gamak Kataki Highway' (Village-Edge Highway):**

The story mourns the loss of the village's naturalness, innocence, and organic character in the face of physical 'development.' Abha Jha calls it 'a writer's inner lament, moved by the end of the village's rusticity, simplicity, and naturalness.'

**'Chhutkik Ek Din' (One Day of Holiday):**

A happy-ending story about two educated young people who marry against social convention (inter-caste or inter-community, the essay implies) but retain their devotion to Maithili literature and Maithil society. Abha Jha notes this as evidence of Ashok's belief that social change and cultural loyalty can coexist.

**'Swadhin' (Independent/Free):**

This story 'vigorously protests marital rape.' A self-respecting woman refuses under any circumstances to carry the child that would result from a forced conjugal relation. Yet she does not seek divorce, saying 'I want to start the story, not end it' — she recognises that her husband is not entirely bad, and refuses to abandon the marriage entirely. Abha Jha comments perceptively: a male author can access a female character's inner experience because, while writing, 'he is neither male nor female — he is only the character.' She connects this to the woman character Bimla in another story, imprisoned but asking why, if she was made president, she was not given presidential authority — a powerful critique of tokenism.

**'Umki':**

Described by Abha Jha as superficially a love story but, following the principle 'ati sarvatra varjayet' (excess in everything must be avoided), with a frightening conclusion: 'Is this too a form of love? Does love also have a quota — this much need, this much supply, after which...?' Her reading draws out the story's disturbing question about possessive obsession.

**Other stories — 'Chal' (Deception), 'Mansooba' (Ambition), 'Khushiki Naam Jeevan' (Life Named Happiness), 'Abhayk Betakem Dui Taa Daant Bhelanhi' (Abhay's Son Got Two Teeth), 'Ena Bh' Kay Kiyo' (Some People Do This), 'O Duno Cycle Sikhaita' (Both of Them Learn to Ride), 'Raag', 'Lemon Ice Cream':**

Abha Jha reviews these stories with equal attention, noting a theatre-vividness in 'Chal', a concern with youth's neglect of family responsibility in 'Mansooba', the acceptance of inter-caste marriage in 'Khushiki Naam Jeevan', an optimistic outlook in 'Abhayk Betakem', a pointing toward mental illness in 'Ena Bh' Kay Kiyo', and finding several of the remaining stories 'good reads.'

## 2.3 Abha Jha's Conclusion

Her essay ends with a summative critical statement, as precise and balanced as her preceding analysis: 'In brief, Daidigam is a collection of fifteen fine, pleasant stories by a sensitive storyteller. The presentation of the stories is beautiful and captivating. Merely expressing concern is not the writer's goal; rather, through the medium of his characters, he creates an ideal situation on the realistic ground — this is the distinctiveness of the storyteller.' She closes: 'Congratulations to the storyteller from an extremely ordinary reader!'

This closing gesture — the self-description as 'extremely ordinary reader' — is a form of Maithili literary modesty (vinay) that simultaneously enacts Kshemendra's auchitya (the fitting thing) for a critical essay about a living writer: the critic must not claim too much authority, must remain in the service of both the text and its author. But the essay's own quality makes the self-description ironic: there is nothing 'extremely ordinary' about this reading.

# III. Critical Analysis through Indian Literary Theory

## 3.1 Rasa Theory and Abha Jha's Critical Sensibility

Bharata Muni's Natyashastra requires that the critic or aesthete be a sahrdaya — a 'fellow-hearted one,' someone with the cultivated emotional and aesthetic sensitivity to receive the rasa generated by a literary work. Abha Jha's critical essay demonstrates precisely this sahrdaya quality: she responds to each story's emotional register — the karunarasa (pathos) of Raghuvansh Babu's nostalgia, the virarasic (heroic) dimension of the independent woman in 'Swadhin', the bhayanaka (frightening) turn at the end of 'Umki' — with calibrated emotional accuracy.

Her identification of 'madhyamarg' (middle path) as Ashok's dominant aesthetic orientation maps onto the rasa framework's concept of shantarasa — the rasa of philosophical equanimity, the state that arises from seeing beyond both extreme optimism and extreme pessimism to a balanced, truth-grounded vision. She reads Ashok as a writer who generates shantarasa not by escaping social reality but by looking at it steadily and finding in it the possibility of constructive response. Her own critical essay enacts the same quality: balanced, steady, neither effusive nor harsh.

## 3.2 Dhvani Theory (Anandavardhana)

Anandavardhana's dhvani — the suggestive resonance that exceeds the literal — is both the object of Abha Jha's critical attention and the method of her own essay. She consistently attends to what Ashok's stories suggest beyond what they literally narrate. In her reading of 'Daidigam', the literal story (a retired man returns to his village) carries the dhvani of a larger question about the Maithili diaspora's responsibility to the language and community they left behind. In 'Gamak Kataki Highway', the literal highway carries the dhvani of the destruction of everything the Maithili village historically embodied. In 'Swadhin', the literal marital situation carries the dhvani of women's fundamental right to bodily autonomy within marriage.

Her essay itself practises dhvani: her closing praise — 'congratulations from an extremely ordinary reader' — carries the suggestion of its opposite. She is not ordinary; and her congratulations are not mere politeness but a genuine critical recognition of Ashok's achievement. The understatement suggests the fullness of appreciation that direct praise would not.

### 3.3 Vakrokti (Kuntaka)

Kuntaka's vakrokti identifies literary beauty in oblique, productive deviation from the ordinary. Abha Jha's critical essay opens with a classical Sanskrit axiom — a productive deviation from the expected modern critical essay's opening. This vakrokti at the level of essay architecture signals from the first sentence that her critical approach is one of elevated seriousness: she measures contemporary Maithili fiction against the standards of the classical tradition.

Her most striking vakrokti is her reading of 'Swadhin': she devotes a long passage to analysing how a male author (Ashok) can write from inside a female character's consciousness without falsifying it. Her argument — that 'while writing, the writer is neither male nor female, only the character' — is a vakrokti (oblique statement) about the nature of literary empathy: it says obliquely what a direct statement about male authors writing women's experience would say clumsily.

### 3.4 Auchitya (Kshemendra)

Kshemendra's auchitya — the fitness of every element to its context — governs Abha Jha's critical method throughout. Her essay is auchita in its language: she uses Sanskrit classical vocabulary ('ati sarvatra varjayet', 'gadyam kavinam nikasham'), contemporary Maithili critical idiom, and occasional Hindi formulations appropriate to the mixed register of contemporary Maithili literary discourse. Her tone is auchita — serious but not pedantic, admiring but not sycophantic, critical without being harsh. Her length is auchita: five pages (pp. 29–33) is the right space for a survey of a fifteen-story collection.

## IV. Critical Analysis through Western Literary Theory

### 4.1 Feminist Criticism: Reading 'Swadhin' and Women's Interiority

The most significant dimension of Abha Jha's essay for feminist literary criticism is her reading of the story 'Swadhin' (Independent/Free). Her analysis of how Ashok represents the inner life of a woman who refuses to carry the child of marital rape — while remaining in the marriage — is a sophisticated engagement with the literary representation of women's bodily autonomy.

Her argument that 'a male author can access the inner experience of a female character' because the writer transcends gender in the act of composition recalls Helene Cixous's concept of bisexuality in writing (The Laugh of the Medusa, 1975): the truly creative writer is not confined to the gender that the social world assigns. But Abha Jha's formulation is more precise than Cixous's: it is not that Ashok becomes female while writing, but that he becomes neither male nor female — he becomes the character. This is a more nuanced position, closer to Keats's concept of 'negative capability' (the capacity to be 'in uncertainties, mysteries, doubts, without any irritable reaching after fact and reason') than to Cixous's more radical claim.

Her reading of Bimla (the woman imprisoned for acting on her political authority) alongside the 'Swadhin' protagonist establishes a feminist critical pattern across the collection: Ashok consistently creates female characters who insist on the full exercise of the authority they are nominally granted. The imprisoned Bimla's question — 'If you made me president, why didn't you give me presidential work?' — is, as Abha Jha reads it, a precise critique of tokenism, the practice of granting titles without substance that characterises the treatment of women in both political and domestic Maithili institutions.

## 4.2 New Criticism: Close Reading and Organic Unity

New Criticism's insistence on close reading — on attending to the text itself rather than to the author's biography or the reader's emotional response — is the implicit method of Abha Jha's essay. She does not discuss Ashok's life (the Visheshshank provides that separately); she discusses the stories. Her readings are close, specific, and grounded in the stories' actual language and narrative choices.

Her identification of 'madhyamarg' as the collection's unifying thematic is a New Critical argument for organic unity: the claim that a collection's fifteen stories are unified by a single vision or aesthetic commitment. Her evidence is drawn from specific narrative details — the young villager's speech in 'Daidigam', the highway's effect on the village in 'Gamak Kataki Highway', the marriage plot in 'Chhutkik Ek Din' — that collectively establish the pattern. This is close reading in its most disciplined form.

## 4.3 Postcolonial and Subaltern Studies

The Ashok Visheshshank is itself an act of counter-canonical recovery: it dedicates an entire Videha issue to a writer who, as the series title 'Jeebait Muda Upekshit' (Living But Neglected) indicates, has not received adequate

recognition from the Sahitya Akademi mainstream. Abha Jha's contribution to this recovery project is her critical legitimation of Ashok's work through rigorous close reading. She does not merely celebrate; she analyses. Her analysis demonstrates that Ashok's fiction merits the serious critical attention that the mainstream has withheld.

Her reading of 'Daidigam' has a specifically postcolonial dimension: the story concerns the Maithili diaspora's responsibility to its place of origin — a question that is structurally postcolonial (the relation between those who have migrated to metropolitan spaces and those who remain in the rural 'periphery'). Her framing of Ashok's position as finding the 'middle path' between diaspora nostalgia and local reality maps onto Homi Bhabha's concept of the 'third space' — the space of cultural negotiation that is neither the origin nor the destination but the ongoing, unresolved process of their relation.

## V. Navya-Nyaya Epistemological Analysis (Gangesa Upadhyaya)

### 5.1 The Critical Essay as Pramana

Gangesa Upadhyaya's Tattvacintamani analyses the conditions under which verbal testimony (shabda) constitutes valid cognition (pramana). For a critical essay to function as pramana — as a reliable instrument of literary knowledge — its author must be an apta: a person with (a) direct knowledge of the text being assessed, (b) sincere intent in communicating that knowledge, and (c) the linguistic and critical competence to communicate it accurately.

Abha Jha's essay meets all three conditions. She has clearly read Ashok's Daidigam attentively — her story-by-story summary demonstrates direct acquaintance with fifteen stories, their plots, characters, and thematic concerns. Her sincerity is evident in both her praise and her minor reservations (implicit in phrases like 'some concern is expressed'). Her competence is demonstrated by her opening with Sanskrit aesthetic theory, maintaining an appropriate critical register, and arriving at a summative judgment that is both precise and fair.

## 5.2 Pratyaksha: The Direct Perception of Fictional Reality

Gangesa's category of vishishta-pratyaksha (qualified or determinate perception) — the perception that grasps both the particular and the universal simultaneously — describes what Abha Jha performs in her best critical moments. When she reads the young villager's speech in 'Daidigam' (rejecting temple-building in favour of hospitals and schools), she perceives the particular moment (a character in a story speaks) and simultaneously the universal that the particular instantiates (the Maithili diaspora's feudal tendency vs. the village's developmental needs). This is critical pratyaksha: the perception of the universal social truth in the particular narrative detail.

## 5.3 Upamana: The Middle Path as Analogy

Gangesa's upamana-pramana (analogical cognition) operates through the recognition of resemblance between a familiar concept and an unfamiliar one. Abha Jha's use of 'madhyamarg' (the middle path — a concept familiar from Buddhist, Jain, and Sanskrit philosophical traditions) as a critical framework for Ashok's fiction is precisely an upamana: she recognises the resemblance between Ashok's narrative strategy (avoiding both pure idealism and pure cynicism) and the philosophical middle path (avoiding both extreme pleasure-seeking and extreme asceticism). The analogy illuminates both the fiction and the philosophical concept.

## 5.4 Anumana: Inference from Narrative Evidence

Abha Jha's critical essay enacts anumana (inference) throughout: from the observed particulars of individual stories (the hetu — the inferential mark), she infers the general character of the collection (the sadhya — what is to be proved). Her inference is: 'Ashok is a sensitive storyteller who seeks the middle path between yatharth (realism) and aadarsh (idealism).' Her evidence is the accumulation of specific narrative observations across fifteen stories — each story functioning as a separate hetu — that together establish the vyapti (invariable concomitance) licencing the inference.

# VI. Position within the Videha Parallel History Framework

## 6.1 The Critic as Participant in the Parallel Tradition

The Videha Parallel History Framework privileges not only creative voices but critical ones: the parallel tradition requires critics who can analyse and legitimise its creative achievements with the same rigour that the canonical tradition's critics apply to the mainstream canon. Abha Jha's essay contributes to this critical project: by bringing classical Sanskrit aesthetics (the gadyam-nikasham maxim) alongside contemporary close reading to the assessment of Ashok's fiction, she demonstrates that the parallel tradition's works deserve and can sustain serious critical engagement.

Her participation in the Ashok Visheshshank — the ninth in Videha's series of special issues on living but neglected Maithili writers — connects her to the movement's central counter-canonical project: the recovery of significant literary figures from the obscurity that the Sahitya Akademi's exclusive recognition structures have imposed on them. Her critical voice is one instrument of this recovery.

## 6.2 The Woman Critic in the Parallel Tradition

In the context of the Videha Parallel History Framework's attention to women's voices, Abha Jha's role as literary critic is as significant as any creative role. The critical apparatus of a literary movement is not gender-neutral: the voices that shape how a tradition reads and values its own texts are as determinative of the tradition's character as the voices that create those texts. Abha Jha's presence among the Ashok Visheshshank's twenty-two critical contributors — as one of the issue's women critics — is a small but concrete element of the feminisation of Maithili literary criticism that the Videha movement has been working to achieve.

Her particular contribution to feminist critical thinking — the passage on 'Swadhin' about the male author's access to female interiority, and the reading of Bimla as critique of tokenism — is a form of feminist critical practice that works not through separate women-focused critical essays but through the integration of feminist reading into a mainstream critical assessment. This 'mainstreaming' of feminist reading is arguably more effective than keeping feminist criticism in a separate 'Stri Kona' (Women's Corner) — it insists that

the question of how fiction represents women is a question for all criticism, not a specialist sub-genre.

## VII. Summary Assessment

Abha Jha is a Maithili literary critic whose one attested work in the Videha archive — the critical essay 'Daidigam — Madhyamargak Anweshanki Katha' (Videha Issue 369, 2023, pp. 29–33) — demonstrates considerable critical intelligence, literary sensitivity, and methodological range. The essay is notable for:

**Classical grounding:**

The opening Sanskrit axiom ('Gadyam kavinam nikasham vadanti') establishes a rigorous evaluative standard derived from the classical Alamkara-shastra tradition and applies it to contemporary Maithili social realism — a methodological bridge between the classical and the contemporary that is characteristic of the best criticism in the Videha parallel tradition.

**Thematic precision:**

The identification of 'madhyamarg' (the middle path) as the governing orientation of Ashok's Daidigam is a precise and generative critical insight — one that illuminates the collection as a whole and provides a coherent framework for reading its fifteen individual stories.

**Feminist critical awareness:**

The analysis of 'Swadhin' (the story of marital rape and a woman's refusal) and the reading of Bimla (the woman who protests tokenistic authority) demonstrate an integrated feminist critical consciousness — feminist reading practised not as a separate critical mode but as part of a holistic literary assessment.

**Auchitya of tone:**

The essay's balanced, non-sycophantic, genuinely engaged critical tone — closing with 'congratulations from an extremely ordinary reader' while being nothing of the kind — is a model of the Maithili critical vinay (modesty) that the parallel tradition values.

**Epistemological validity:**

In Gangesa Upadhyaya's terms, the essay is valid shabda-pramana: the testimony of an apta (a trustworthy, knowledgeable, sincere testifier) about a

literary text. Its knowledge-claims are grounded in pratyaksha (direct reading of the stories), structured through anumana (inference from narrative particulars to thematic generalisations), and enriched by upamana (the middle-path analogy).

Abha Jha's literary-critical voice belongs to the category of voices the Videha Parallel History Framework has consistently identified as undervalued: the woman critic who brings both classical learning and contemporary social consciousness to the assessment of Maithili fiction. Her one attested essay is enough to establish her as a significant critical presence in the late period of the Videha parallel movement.

## VIII. Archival Reference

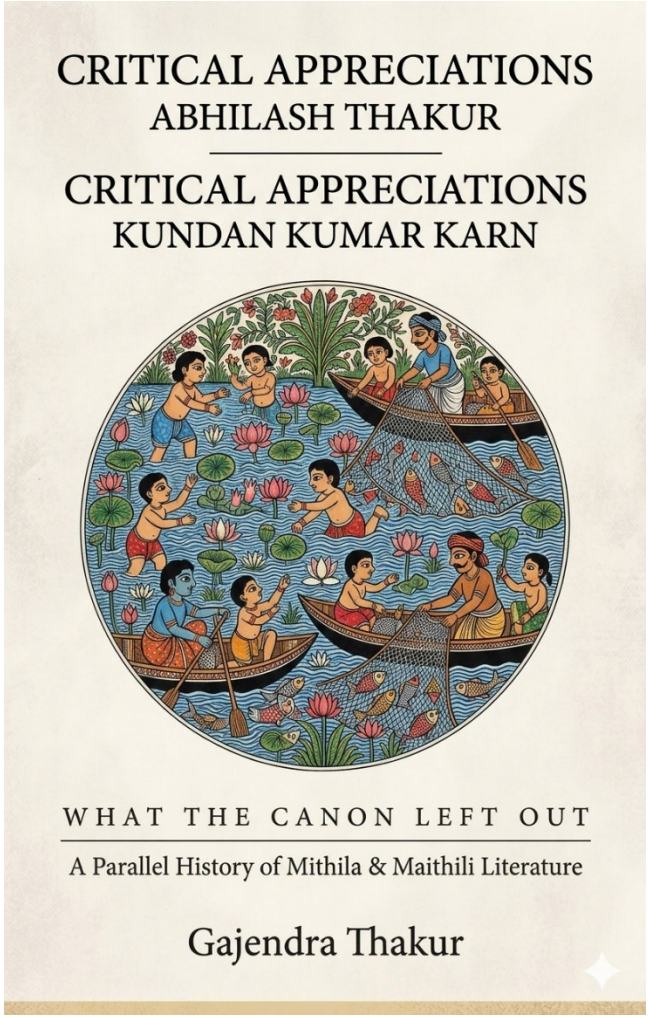
Primary source: Videha Issue 369 (Ashok Visheshshank, 2023), VIDEHA_369_2_Devanagari.docx, paragraphs 132–155: 'Abha Jha — Daidigam: Madhyamargak Anweshanki Katha', pp. 29–33. Text begins: 'Sanskrit mein ek tayakyans chhaik — Gadyam kavinam nikasham vadanti...' Full essay extracted from the Videha archive.

The story collection under review: Ashok, Daidigam (2017), containing fifteen stories: Daidigam, Gamak Kataki Highway, Chhutkik Ek Din, Swadhin, Umki, Chal, Mansooba, Khushiki Naam Jeevan, Abhayk Betakem Dui Taa Daant Bhelanhi, Ena Bh' Kay Kiyo, O Duno Cycle Sikhaita, Raag, Lemon Ice Cream, and two others mentioned in passing.

Indian theoretical sources: Bharata Muni, Natyashastra; Abhinavagupta, Abhinavabharati; Anandavardhana, Dhvanyaloka; Kuntaka, Vakroktijivita; Kshemendra, Auchityavicharacharchaa; Gangesa Upadhyaya, Tattvacintamani (c. 1325 CE, Mithila).

Western theoretical sources: Helene Cixous, The Laugh of the Medusa (1975); John Keats, Letters (negative capability, 1817); Cleanth Brooks, The Well Wrought Urn (1947); Homi Bhabha, The Location of Culture (1994); Ranajit Guha, Subaltern Studies Vol. I (1982).

**LESSON 008 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**




# CRITICAL APPRECIATIONS

**ABHILASH THAKUR**

&

CRITICAL APPRECIATIONS

**KUNDAN KUMAR KARN**

*I*

CRITICAL APPRECIATIONS

**ABHILASH THAKUR**

*Indian & Western Literary Theory · Videha Parallel History Framework*

*Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa · Rasa-Dhvani-Vakrokti-Auchitya*

# I. BIOGRAPHICAL PROFILE

## A. Identity and Formation

Abhilash Thakur (अभिलाष ठाकुर) is a Maithili fiction writer and satirist who has contributed primarily in the bīhani kathā (very short story / flash fiction) and satirical micro-essay forms to the Videha archive. His surname Thakur is widely distributed across communities in Bihar and Mithila. His given name Abhilash (meaning 'desire/aspiration') carries a Sanskritic register. His documented contributions in two Sadeha volumes demonstrate a writer whose strengths lie in compression, irony, and contemporary social observation.

## B. Videha Archive: Complete Works Catalogue

Videha Sadeha 20 (Prelim_20): Bīhani Kathā — Sāṃṭha Gāṃṭha (साँठ गाँठ — Collusion/Back-scratching) and Noṭabandī (नोटबन्दी — Demonetisation), p. 605. Two bīhani kathā on contemporary social and political themes.

Videha Sadeha 24 (Prelim_24): Ṭakadyāna (टकध्यान — Fixated on Money / Money-Meditation), p. 558. A single bīhani kathā or satirical piece on the theme of monetary obsession.

# II. WORKS ANALYSIS

## A. Bīhani Kathā as Form

The bīhani kathā (बीहनि कथा) — Maithili's 'very short story' or flash fiction form — is one of the Videha archive's most characteristic contributions to Maithili literary innovation. Developed and championed by Gajendra Thakur as a native Maithili equivalent of the international micro-fiction/flash fiction movement, the bīhani kathā typically runs to a single page or less, uses a sharp narrative compression, and aims at a single striking reversal, revelation, or insight. Its etymology — bīhani meaning 'dawn' or 'first thing/very small' — positions it as the smallest functional unit of narrative fiction.

Abhilash Thakur's contributions to this form are notable for their subject matter: both 'Sāṃṭha Gāṃṭha' (collusion) and 'Noṭabandī' (demonetisation) address contemporary social-political realities. Demonetisation (Noṭabandī) — the November 2016 Indian government decision to demonetise all Rs 500 and Rs 1000 banknotes, affecting the entire informal economy of rural Bihar and Mithila profoundly — is a particularly timely and sharply observed subject for the micro-fiction form. The bīhani kathā's compression is perfectly suited to capturing the instantaneous social disruption of demonetisation: the flash narrative form mirrors the flash policy change.

## B. 'Sāṃṭha Gāṃṭha' (Collusion)

Sāṃṭha Gāṃṭha — literally 'joint arrangement' or 'fixing' — is a common Maithili/Hindi idiom for behind-the-scenes collusion between parties who appear to be in opposition. As a bīhani kathā title, it points toward the social-political critique of apparent oppositions that conceal real alliances — a theme with direct relevance to Bihar's political landscape, where caste-based party coalitions frequently involve precisely this kind of collusive arrangement between formally competing interests.

The choice of this term as a narrative title reflects the bīhani kathā's characteristic move: the title itself is a concentrated concept that the story then unpacks or illustrates through a concrete narrative incident. The best bīhani kathā creates a gap between the expected/named and the actual, using narrative reversal to illuminate the social reality that the title names abstractly.

### C. 'Noṭabandī' (Demonetisation)

The demonetisation story is Abhilash Thakur's most politically topical contribution. Noṭabandī — the November 2016 demonetisation — had a severe impact on rural Bihar, where cash-based informal transactions constitute the primary mode of economic activity for agricultural communities, daily wage workers, and small traders. The impact on Mithila's agricultural economy — during which queues at ATMs stretched through the night and agricultural transactions ground to a halt — provided material for powerful social observation.

Writing a bīhani kathā about Noṭabandī in Maithili for the Videha archive is a documentarily important act: it captures the social experience of a major policy disruption from the perspective of the Maithili-speaking rural community, in their own language, at a moment when Hindi and English media were focusing primarily on the national political narrative. The bīhani kathā form — with its preference for the specific, concrete incident over the abstract policy analysis — is ideally suited to conveying the human experience of the policy's impact.

### D. 'Ṭakadyāna' (Money-Meditation)

Ṭakadyāna (टकध्यान) is a compound of Ṭakā (money/rupee) and Dhyāna (meditation/concentration) — literally 'money-meditation' or 'fixated on money'. The ironic yoking of the sacred concept of dhyāna (meditation in the yogic and Buddhist traditions, the focused meditative state as the path to enlightenment) with the profane concept of Ṭakā (money) is a satirical move consistent with the bīhani kathā's love of the comic-ironic. The compound suggests a person whose entire consciousness is absorbed in money — their 'dhyāna' (meditation, focus) is on Ṭakā rather than on the divine. This is vakrokti in its purest form: the sacred word (dhyāna) placed in sacrilegious adjacency to the profane (Ṭakā) to create a satirical critique of materialist consciousness.

## III. THEORETICAL FRAMEWORKS

### A. Navya-Nyāya: The Anumāna of Satirical Fiction

Gaṅgeśa's analysis of anumāna (inference) through vyāpti (universal concomitance) provides a framework for understanding satirical fiction's

epistemic logic. The satirical bīhani kathā works through an implied anumāna: the hetu (the specific observed social fact — a collusion between political opponents, the human impact of demonetisation, a person's total absorption in money) leads through a vyāpti (the universal principle that the satire assumes — that political collusion is endemic, that economic policy disrupts ordinary people's lives, that modern materialist consciousness displaces the spiritual) to a sādhya (the unstated conclusion — the critique of the social structure that produces these phenomena).

The Navya-Nyāya tradition's concern with the precision of the vyāpti — the universal concomitance that grounds valid inference — is relevant to the satirist's concern with the accuracy of the generalisation that their specific example is meant to illustrate. A satirical piece that rests on a false or poorly generalised vyāpti is bad satire as well as bad logic: it creates the illusion of insight without the substance.

## B. Brecht and the Short Form

Bertolt Brecht's theory of the Lehrstück (learning play) and his advocacy of short, defamiliarising narrative forms that interrupt habitual perception and provoke critical thought provides a Western theatrical-literary parallel to the bīhani kathā's aesthetic programme. Brecht's concept of Verfremdungseffekt (estrangement effect) — the technique of making the familiar strange so that it can be critically examined rather than passively accepted — is structurally analogous to the bīhani kathā's characteristic narrative move: a specific incident that makes a familiar social reality suddenly visible and questionable.

The Noṭabandī bīhani kathā's power lies precisely in this defamiliarisation: by narrating the human experience of demonetisation as a specific fictional incident, it makes visible the abstraction 'demonetisation policy' as a set of concrete, embodied disruptions to actual people's actual lives — the Brechtian move from policy to person.

## C. Irony and the Maithili Satirical Tradition

The Maithili satirical tradition — with its roots in Harimohan Jha's celebrated comic prose (Kanyādāna, KhaTTar Kakkāka Taraṃg) and the broader tradition of Maithili wit — provides the indigenous critical framework for Abhilash Thakur's satirical micro-fiction. Harimohan Jha's comedy depended on the precise observation of Maithili social pretensions — the gap between the claimed dignity of Maithil Brahmin social norms and the actual petty materiality of their practice. Thakur's Ṭakadyāna and Sāṃṭha Gāṃṭha operate

in the same satirical mode: the gap between claimed ideals (spiritual meditation, democratic opposition) and actual practice (money fixation, political collusion) is the structural engine of the satire.

### D. Videha Parallel History Framework

Abhilash Thakur's bīhani kathā contributions are emblematic of the Videha Parallel History's championing of the bīhani kathā form as a distinctively Maithili contribution to world micro-fiction. The form's preference for the concrete, politically observed, and satirically sharp over the aesthetically elaborate or culturally nostalgic aligns it perfectly with the Parallel History's democratic orientation. His Noṭabandī piece captures a specific moment of economic disruption in Mithila's history — a moment that would not have been documented in Maithili without Videha's commitment to the full range of Maithili civic experience.

## IV. SELECT BIBLIOGRAPHY

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II

CRITICAL APPRECIATIONS

**KUNDAN KUMAR KARN**

*Indian & Western Literary Theory · Videha Parallel History Framework*
*Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa · Rasa-Dhvani-Vakrokti-Auchitya*

# I. BIOGRAPHICAL PROFILE

## A. Identity and Formation

Kundan Kumar Karn (कुन्दन कुमार कर्ण) is one of the most prolific and generically innovative ghazal poets in the Videha archive, with confirmed contributions across five Sadeha volumes (Sadeha 7, 14, 15, 16, and 24). His surname Karn (कर्ण) — the Maithili form of Karṇa, the tragic hero of the Mahābhārata — carries resonances of the underprivileged genius, the unrecognised master, the figure of exceptional ability denied proper recognition by the dominant institution. Whether this is the intended register of his surname or not, it acquires meaning within the Videha Parallel History Framework's recurrent theme of excellence marginalised by the canonical establishment.

The given name Kundan (meaning 'refined gold' or 'pure gold') combined with Karn creates a name-compound with a quietly heroic dignity. His Videha contributions demonstrate a poet of considerable formal range: standard ghazal, āzād ghazal (free ghazal without radif constraint), hajal (the comic-satirical hybrid of hazl and ghazal), bāla ghazal (children's ghazal), and the satirical micro-poem 'Āora Chichiyāu'.

## B. Videha Archive: Complete Works Catalogue

Videha Sadeha 7 (Prelim_7): Āzād Ghazal 1–3. Free/liberated ghazals — a form that retains the ghazal's sher structure and radif but dispenses with the strict bahr constraint, allowing greater metrical freedom.

Videha Sadeha 14 (Prelim_14): Bāla Ghazal + Ghazal, pp. 496–497. Children's ghazals alongside a standard adult ghazal.

Videha Sadeha 15 (Prelim_15): Kichu Ghazal + Aṃganāme Kucala Kauā (अंगनामे कुचरल कौआ — The Crow Scratching in the Courtyard), pp. 176–178.

Videha Sadeha 16 (Prelim_16): Hajal + Kichu Bāla Ghazal + Kichu Ghazal, pp. 640–657 — his largest single contribution, eighteen pages, including the hajal form which is unique in the archive.

Videha Sadeha 24 (Prelim_24): Āora Chichiyāu (आओर छिछियाउ — Squeal More / Hiss Even More), p. 569. A single satirical poem with a provocative title.

## II. GENERIC INNOVATIONS

### A. The Hajal: Comic-Satirical Hybrid

Karn's most formally innovative contribution is the hajal (हजल) — a word that blends hazl (Persian/Urdu: jest, satire, comic mode) with ghazal to create a specifically comic-satirical version of the ghazal form. The hajal is not a new form — it has precedents in Urdu literature where Akbar Allahabadi and others used the ghazal form for political and social satire — but its appearance in the Videha Maithili archive in Karn's contributions (Sadeha 7 has 'हजल' in Manu's section, and Sadeha 16 has Karn's own hajals) marks an important moment in Maithili ghazal's generic development.

The hajal's defining characteristic is the deployment of the ghazal's formal rigour (bahr, radif, qāfiya, sher structure) in the service of comic, satirical, or politically ironic content — precisely the content that the dignified classical ghazal traditionally excludes. This formal-content incongruity is itself a major resource of the hajal: the mismatch between the elevated form and the lowered or comic content produces the comic-satirical effect. Ashish Anchinhar references this form in his preface to Pradeep Pushpa's collection as well — confirming its place within the broader Videha ghazal tradition.

### B. 'Aṃganāme Kucala Kauā' (The Crow Scratching in the Courtyard)

This piece — whose title is itself a poetic image — belongs to the tradition of Maithili nature poetry that uses birds and animals as vehicles for social and

moral observation. The crow (kauā) is one of the most culturally loaded birds in the Indian tradition: associated with ancestors (pitṛpakṣa — the fortnight of ancestral offerings specifically involves feeding crows), with intelligence and cunning, with the liminal space between the domestic and the wild (crows live on human refuse and habitation), and with the subaltern — the scavenger who survives on the margins of the social order.

A crow 'scratching' (kucalana — also meaning 'crushing', 'trampling') in the courtyard (aṃgana) is a richly ambiguous image. The courtyard is the central domestic space of the Maithili household — the locus of ritual, social, and family life. The crow in the courtyard is an intruder — liminal, uncomfortable, uninvited but impossible to ignore. 'Kucalana' adds a further dimension: the crow is not merely present but actively disturbing the order of the courtyard. This is either a naturalistic observation elevated into a social-moral image, or (more likely) a social-moral allegory using the naturalistic image as its vehicle.

## C. 'Āora Chichiyāu' (Squeal More / Hiss Even More)

This provocative title — Āora Chichiyāu, literally 'squeal/hiss even more' — is the most direct example of the hajal/satirical mode in Karn's corpus. Chichiyānā (to squeal, to make a high-pitched complaining sound, to protest in a helpless manner) is an onomatopoeic word with comic-derisive connotations in Maithili: it suggests ineffectual protest, the sound of someone who cannot act effectively and can only squeal. 'Āora chichiyāu' — 'squeal even more' — is an ironic address to such a protester: the invitation to continue their ineffectual noise implies that the noise changes nothing.

The satirical target is likely the political complainer — the citizen who protests loudly but ineffectively against social injustice, corruption, or governmental failure. The title's address (imperative form: 'you squeal more') places the reader/addressee in the position of the ineffectual protester, creating an unsettling satirical mirror. This is vakrokti in its most direct form: the unexpected imperative address forces the reader to confront their own complicity in ineffectual protest.

## D. Bāla Ghazal: Pedagogy and Form

Karn's bāla ghazal contributions (Sadeha 14 and within Sadeha 16's 'Kichu Bāla Ghazal') place him among the pioneers of this Videha-developed form. The bāla ghazal adapts the ghazal's formal structure — bahr, radif, sher — for a child audience through simpler vocabulary, accessible imagery, playful rhymes, and educational content. The form serves the double purpose of teaching children

both literary forms (the ghazal's structure) and language (Maithili vocabulary, rhyme patterns).

The development of a children's ghazal tradition is a significant contribution to Maithili's institutional future: it introduces the ghazal form to children through accessible, enjoyable composition, building a reader and writer base for the adult ghazal tradition. This pedagogical-literary project is entirely consistent with the Videha Parallel History's commitment to developing every register and audience of Maithili literature.

## III. THEMATIC ANALYSIS

### A. The Hajal's Social Critique

Karn's hajal and satirical contributions engage with social themes through comic-ironic means. The crow in the courtyard, the imperative to 'squeal more', and the titles of his contributions suggest a satirical orientation toward social inertia, political impotence, and the gap between protest and change. This satirical mode is the most socially engaged strand of Karn's work — it connects to the broader Dushyant Kumar tradition of the politically engaged ghazal that Ashish Anchinhar and Gajendra Thakur have championed within Videha.

### B. Nature Imagery and the Maithili Ecological

The crow poem places Karn within the Maithili nature poetry tradition that treats specific animals, plants, and landscapes as both literal and figurative presences in the literary imagination. This tradition — practised by Shanti Lakshmi Chaudhary (Tilakora, Bathūā, Kumhar), by the folk song tradition's Koshi River and agricultural cycle imagery, and by the classical poetry's mango groves and monsoon clouds — treats Mithila's specific ecology as the primary substance of literary imagination. Karn's crow is a specific Mithila courtyard crow — not an abstract bird but the bird that every Maithili household knows.

# IV. THEORETICAL FRAMEWORKS

## A. Navya-Nyāya and the Hajal's Logic

The hajal's satirical logic operates through what Gaṅgeśa's Navya-Nyāya would call an aprasiddha (unexpected/incongruent) vyāpti — an apparently paradoxical connection between things that are supposed to be separate. The hajal connects the dignified form (ghazal) with the undignified content (satire, complaint, social observation) through a vyāpti that the form itself denies: 'wherever there is a ghazal, there is high seriousness' — a vyāpti the hajal violates through its comic content. This violation of expected vyāpti is both the source of the hajal's humour and the mechanism of its social critique.

The satire 'Āora Chichiyāu' operates through the anumāna: hetu = the addressee squeals (protests helplessly); vyāpti = ineffectual protest changes nothing; sādhya = the invitation to squeal more reveals the futility of complaint without action. The inferential structure is the satirical argument.

## B. Dhvani and the Crow Image

Ānandavardhana's dhvani (suggestion/resonance) is the appropriate analytical tool for the crow poem. 'Aṃganāme Kucala Kauā' generates multiple dhvani simultaneously: the literal image (a crow scratching in the courtyard), the ancestral resonance (crows as vessels of ancestral presence in Maithili ritual), the social dhvani (the intruder who disrupts the domestic order), and the political dhvani (the subaltern who is always already present in the household's life but whose presence is always uncomfortable). No single meaning exhausts the poem's resonance — the dhvani is inexhaustible, which is precisely Ānandavardhana's criterion for great poetry.

## C. Bakhtin: The Carnivalesque Hajal

Bakhtin's carnivalesque provides the framework for the hajal's generic politics. In Bakhtin's analysis, the comic-grotesque tradition (carnival, folk humour, parody) represents the culture of laughter that coexists with and challenges the culture of seriousness — the official literary tradition with its hierarchical norms of form and content. The hajal's deployment of the ghazal's dignified form for comic-satirical content is a Bakhtinian carnivalesque move: it introduces the 'low' (satire, complaint, social observation) into the 'high' (the elevated lyric form) and in doing so challenges the hierarchy that separates them.

### D. Videha Parallel History Framework

Kundan Kumar Karn is among the most formally innovative figures in the Videha ghazal archive. His development of the hajal, his sustained contribution to the bāla ghazal tradition, and his deployment of satirical imagery in the crow poem and 'Āora Chichiyāu' demonstrate the breadth of the Parallel History's ghazal community. His āzād ghazal contributions show a poet willing to relax the formal constraints of the tradition when the content demands it, while his standard ghazals and hajals demonstrate mastery of the strict forms. The Parallel History's documentation of his work across five Sadeha volumes over multiple years ensures that this formally innovative and socially engaged poet has a permanent place in the Maithili literary record.

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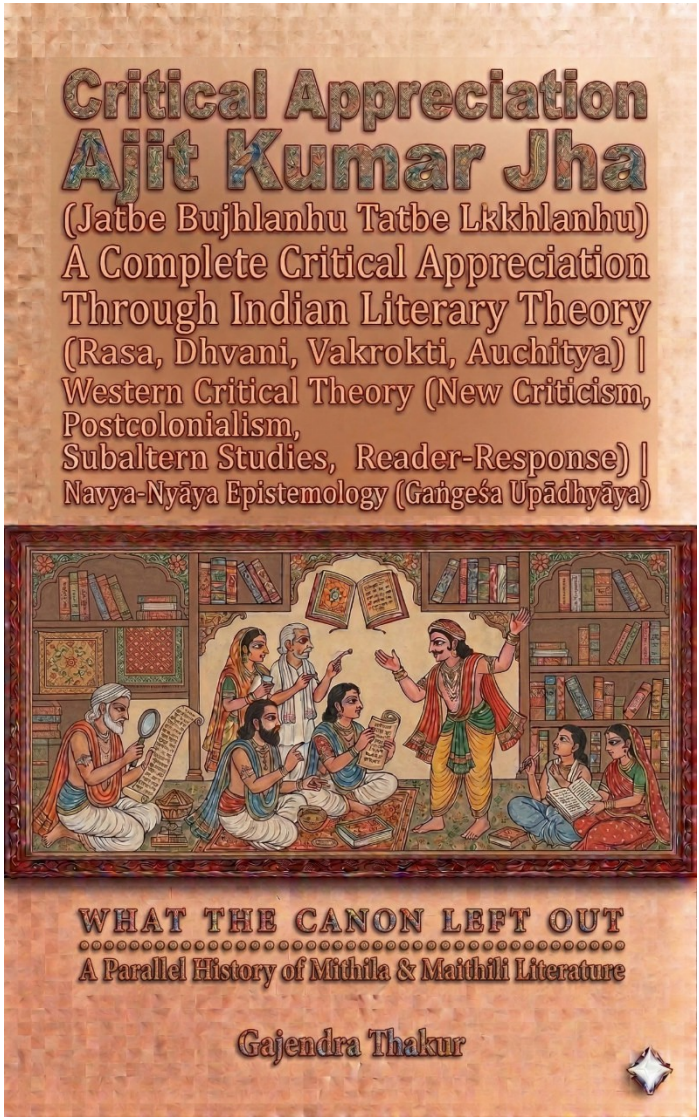
**LESSON 009 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**




# Critical Appreciation

**Ajit Kumar Jha**

*(Jatbe Bujhlanhu Tatbe Likhlanhu)*

A Complete Critical Appreciation

Through Indian Literary Theory (Rasa, Dhvani, Vakrokti, Auchitya) |

Western Critical Theory (New Criticism, Postcolonialism, Subaltern Studies, Reader-Response) |

Navya-Nyāya Epistemology (Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya)

### I. Biographical Profile and Literary Formation

Ajit Kumar Jha (born 6 July 1967, Calcutta; permanent address: Village-P.O. Yajuar, Muzaffarpur, Bihar-843360) is a Maithili literary critic, essayist, and micro-fiction writer whose first and, to date, only published book — जतबे बुझलहुँ ततबे लिखलहुँ (Jatbe Bujhlanhu Tatbe Likhlanhu, Videha eJournal Publication, 2026, ISBN 978-93-5635-145-5) — appeared after three to three-and-a-half decades of active engagement with Maithili literature. His biography is that paradox: thirty years of writing, one book.

Born and educated in Calcutta (BSc, Calcutta University), Jha enlisted in the Indian Air Force, where technical training and postings to nine stations over twenty years shaped an itinerant sensibility intimately familiar with the Maithili diaspora. After service retirement he worked briefly in the private sector in Pune before joining Life Insurance Corporation (LIC), where he is currently posted at Muzaffarpur Branch-1. His literary formation is thus deeply diasporic: Maithili was not his daily spoken medium but an affective and ideological commitment — a voluntary return to motherland through language.

His mentors include the late Rajanandan Lal Das (Karnaamrit), the late Ramlochan Thakur, and the late Premchandra Mishra (Head, Maithili Department, Lalit Narayan Mithila Vishwavidyalaya, Muzaffarpur). The Karnaamrit journal, founded by Rajanandan Lal Das, was Jha's gateway to Maithili literary culture from 1987 onward — a journal he distributed personally among friends, colleagues, and strangers in the tradition of small-press Maithili distribution. He began writing poetry and short fiction (laghu katha) while in the Air Force, published in various Maithili periodicals, and from 2021 became a regular contributor to the Videha eJournal under the mentorship of Ashish Anchinhar.

The book's title — जतबे बुझलहुँ ततबे लिखलहुँ, meaning 'As much as I understood, so much I wrote' — encodes its epistemological humility. It is not the declaration of a system-builder but of an honest percipient: the limit of writing is the limit of understanding, and both are acknowledged as provisional.

| Biographical Detail | Information |
|---|---|
| Full Name | Ajit Kumar Jha (अजित कुमार झा) |

| | |
|---|---|
| Date of Birth | 06 July 1967 |
| Birthplace | Calcutta (Kolkata) |
| Native Village | Yajuar (Yazuar), Muzaffarpur, Bihar |
| Education | BSc, Calcutta University; Diploma in Electrical Engineering, Indian Air Force |
| Career | Indian Air Force (technical, ~20 yrs); private sector Pune; LIC Muzaffarpur Branch-1 |
| Literary Mentors | Rajanandan Lal Das, Ramlochan Thakur, Premchandra Mishra |
| Published Book | Jatbe Bujhlanhu Tatbe Likhlanhu (2026, ISBN 978-93-5635-145-5) |
| Genres | Literary criticism/appreciation, essay, micro-fiction (laghu katha), poetry |
| Email | jha.ajitkumar67@gmail.com |

# II. The Book: Architecture, Contents, and Occasion

## 2.1 Genesis and Editorial Circumstances

The book was assembled not by the author but by Ashish Anchinhar, editor of Anchinhar Akhar and associate editor of Videha, who collected Jha's articles published in Videha over four years, compiled them into book form, and presented the author with a fait accompli. This unusual genesis — a book willed into existence by an editor before the author had willed it — is itself a critical datum. It testifies to the dispersed, collaborative nature of contemporary Maithili literary production, where the distinction between author, editor, and institutional catalyst is fluid.

Jha writes in his preface (Duu Aakhar): 'I never imagined my name would ever appear on a book, and that my first book would be a collection of essays — this is even more astonishing.' He identifies himself not as a writer but as a reader (paathak): 'I consider myself a reader, not a writer.' This performative self-abnegation, in the tradition of Maithili literary modesty, is nonetheless contradicted by the quality and commitment of the essays themselves.

## 2.2 Structure and Contents

The book contains fourteen essays (aalekh) and one reader's response (paathkiy pratikriya), all previously published in Videha special issues. The essays are organized around specific persons — living and recently deceased figures of Maithili literature, journalism, theatre, and cultural activism — and together constitute a portrait gallery of the Maithili parallel literary tradition.

| | Essay Title / Subject | Publication Source (Videha) |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | Van Main Aami — Rajanandan Lal Das | Issue 333, 01 Nov 2021 |
| 2 | Mithila Maithili Aandolanak Pathey — Ravindra Thakur | Issue 348, 15 Jun 2022 |
| 3 | Abaaraa Nahitan: Ek Anupam Kriti (Kedar Nath Chaudhary) | Ashok Special Review |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 4 | Maithili Rangmanchak Prernaasrot — Smt. Premlata Mishra 'Prem' | Videha Special |
| 5 | 'Samay-Saal' ke Akanait — Shardinduju Chaudhary's editorial journal | Issue 358, 15 Nov 2022 |
| 6 | Daidigan: Ek Apratim Katha Sangrah (Ashok — Katha Sangrah) | Issue 369, 01 May 2023 |
| 7 | Gharmuha — Madheshi Aandolan document (Ram Bhorosa Padi 'Bhramar') | Novel review |
| 8 | Ghataatop Anhaariya me Ummiidak Kiran — Mithila Students Union | MSU Special |
| 9 | Sagar Ji — Yatha Naam, Tatha Kaam | Videha Special |
| 10 | Maithilik Succha Sevak — Gajendra Thakur Ji | Gajendra Special |
| 11 | Mithilaak Arthashaastri — Sri Narendra Jha | Videha Special |
| 12 | Mithilaak Samskritik Dharohar ke Raksak — Narayanji Chaudhary | Videha Special |
| 13 | Shivshankar Srinivas Ji: Gaamak Lok (village and modernity) | Issue 424, 15 Aug 2025 |
| 14 | Videha Bhavanath Jha Visheshank par Paathkiy (reader's response) | Issue 428, 15 Oct 2025 |

## 2.3 Thematic Architecture

The fourteen essays collectively enact a single large project: the documentation and critical valuation of the Maithili parallel literary tradition — the democratic, non-canonical, subaltern tradition that the Videha Parallel Literature Movement has been excavating since 2000. Each essay is simultaneously a character portrait, a literary-critical assessment, and a cultural history. The subjects range from editors (Rajanandan Lal Das, Shardinduju

Chaudhary) to lyricists and performing artists (Ravindra Thakur), theatrical directors (Premlata Mishra), fiction writers (Ashok, Ram Bhorosa Padi 'Bhramar'), scholars (Gajendra Thakur, Narendra Jha, Bhavanath Jha, Narayanji Chaudhary), and cultural organizations (MSU, Sagar Ji).

# III. Critical Analysis through Indian Literary Theory

## 3.1 Rasa Theory (Bharata's Natyashastra and Abhinavagupta's Abhinavabharati)

Bharata Muni's Rasa theory, as elaborated by Abhinavagupta (10th-11th century), holds that the aesthetic experience (rasaanubhava) arises from the successful communication of the sthayibhava (permanent emotional state) through the vibhava (excitants), anubhava (consequents), and vyabhicaari bhava (transitory states). Applied to Jha's criticism, the dominant rasa is karunarasa (the rasa of pathos/compassion) — the compassion of a diaspora writer for the unrecognised labourers of Maithili culture.

This is most visible in the essay on Rajanandan Lal Das ('Van Main Aami': 'A One-Man Army'), where Jha narrates a personal encounter with Das — their meeting during a train journey, Das's post-brain-haemorrhage return to Maithili work, his insistence on using the meagre honorarium for a book publication rather than a ceremony, his death-defying commitment. The vibhava here is the scene of Das standing personally at a bus stop to receive a junior writer (Jha himself); the anubhava is Jha's overwhelming shame (lajjaa) that such a senior figure should wait for him; the sthayibhava is shoka (grief) for a tradition that must labour in obscurity. Abhinavagupta would identify the saadharanikaran (universalization) that allows the particular emotion to become shared aesthetic experience: Jha's prose achieves precisely this.

Similarly, in the essay on Ravindra Thakur — the lyricist of the first Maithili film who never received adequate recognition — the underlying rasa is a combination of vira (heroism) and karunarasa: heroic dedication under conditions of pathos. Jha quotes at length the songs of Ravindra Thakur, including the deeply moving dirge for Maithili motherhood ('Janma delanhi maay Mithilaak, seho kane sochu'). The rasaasvada (tasting of rasa) is achieved through the specificity of the lyrics rather than through abstract praising — a technique fully consistent with Bharata's prescription that rasa must arise through concrete representation, not assertion.

## 3.2 Dhvani Theory (Anandavardhana's Dhvanyaaloka)

Anandavardhana (9th century, Kashmir) identified dhvani (resonance/suggestion) as the soul of poetry: the suggested meaning (vyangya artha) exceeds and transcends the literal meaning (vaachya artha). While Jha

writes prose criticism, his best essays operate through a strong dhvani dimension — the suggested meaning is invariably larger than the stated argument.

In the essay on Gajendra Thakur ('Maithilik Succha Sevak'), the literal level describes Thakur's contributions to Maithili digital literature. But the dhvani is a meditation on the nature of service (seva) in a tradition where seva goes unrecognized: the phrase 'succha sevak' (genuine/pure servant) resonates against the unstated background of those who serve Maithili for social prestige or institutional reward. The suggestion is that genuineness is verified by the absence of institutional recognition — a profoundly counter-canonical epistemological claim made through suggestion rather than argument.

In the essay on Shardinduju Chaudhary's journal Samay-Saal, Jha's discussion of what he calls the journal's lapse into obscenity (the pseudonymous 'Latika' column) works through dhvani: his criticism of the column is mild in denotation but the resonance of the critique is that small-press Maithili journals have consistently undermined their own dignity, gesturing toward the structural problem of Maithili literary self-sabotage without naming it.

## 3.3 Vakrokti Theory (Kuntaka's Vakroktijivita, c. 10th century)

Kuntaka's theory of vakrokti (oblique/deviant expression) holds that literary beauty arises from a productive deviation from ordinary usage — the twist (vaikritya) that makes language literarily alive. In Jha's prose, vakrokti operates at the level of title and structure rather than at the lexical level. The title जतबे बुझलहुँ ततबे लिखलहुँ is itself a vakroktis: it appears to be a modest disclaimer but it is actually a sophisticated epistemological statement — the equivalence of understanding and writing implies that writing is not a transcription of pre-existing knowledge but the very act of understanding. The twist in this statement is that it converts a limitation into a theory of composition.

Similarly, the essay on Kedar Nath Chaudhary ('Abaara Nahitan') narrates a near-suicide, a chance encounter with fried sweets (jelebis and chaudhary) — the absurd proximity of death and snack — that saved both Chaudhary and the first Maithili film. This is Kuntaka's vakrokti at the narrative level: the oblique approach to a serious subject (the founding of Maithili cinema) through a comic episode that is also genuinely moving.

## 3.4 Auchitya Theory (Kshemendra's Auchityavicharacharchaa, c. 11th century)

Kshemendra's theory of auchitya (propriety, appropriateness) holds that the ultimate criterion of literary excellence is the fitness of every element to every other element — word to meaning, character to action, style to subject. Applied to Jha's criticism, auchitya becomes both a critical tool and a problematic. The essays on living persons (Gajendra Thakur, Narendra Jha, Narayanji Chaudhary) raise the auchitya question acutely: is it 'fitting' to write extended critical appreciation of living persons, where the normal institutional machinery for critical distance does not apply?

Jha himself raises this question implicitly when he notes that Maithili critics have traditionally praised their own circle and avoided criticizing those with whom they disagree. He claims Ajit Kumar Jha is 'baacha' (free) from this fault — a claim that the essays themselves largely sustain. The essay on Shardinduju Chaudhary's journal is notably the most critically honest: Jha praises the editorial quality while explicitly criticizing the obscene last-page content. This balance is precisely what Kshemendra means by auchitya: the critical essay must sustain proportionality between praise and reservation, and must not sacrifice truth for friendship or flattery.

# IV. Critical Analysis through Western Literary Theory

## 4.1 New Criticism: Intentional Fallacy, Organic Unity, and Close Reading

New Criticism, as articulated by W.K. Wimsatt and Monroe Beardsley ('The Intentional Fallacy,' 1946; 'The Affective Fallacy,' 1949) and Cleanth Brooks (The Well Wrought Urn, 1947), insists on the autonomy of the literary text from both the author's intention and the reader's emotional response. Applied to Jha's criticism, New Criticism exposes a fundamental tension: Jha's essays are explicitly autobiographical and testimonial, grounding textual evaluation in personal encounter and emotional response. The 'intentional fallacy' is, in Jha's criticism, not a fallacy but a methodology.

Yet Jha's strongest essays achieve something close to the New Critical ideal of 'organic unity' — the sense that every element of the work is functionally integrated. His analysis of the short story collection Daidigan ('Ghost-village') by the writer known as 'Ashok' demonstrates this: Jha traces the thematic coherence of the collection's fifteen stories through their shared concern with the dying Maithili village, social change, and the gap between modernity and tradition. His summary of the final story — in which the NRI returnee Raghuvans decides, upon seeing a local health crisis, to build a hospital rather than a temple — demonstrates Jha's capacity for organic reading: the story's ending resolves all the collection's tensions (tradition vs. modernity, religious identity vs. civic duty, self-interest vs. community) in a single gesture.

The limitation of applying New Criticism to Jha's work is that it would necessarily amputate the social-historical context that is the very substance of the essays. Jha's criticism is always criticism of persons-in-context: the literary text is never abstracted from the institutional and social conditions of its production. This is not a failure of New Criticism's terms but a recognition of their limits.

## 4.2 Postcolonial Theory: Bhabha, Spivak, and the Subaltern Voice

Homi Bhabha's concept of the 'third space' (The Location of Culture, 1994) — the liminal, hybrid space produced by colonial encounter — maps suggestively onto Jha's biographical and critical situation. Jha is a Maithili by birth and affiliation who spent most of his adult life in Hindi-dominant institutional

environments (Indian Air Force, LIC); his Maithili writing is a reclamation performed across this hybrid space. The Air Force section of his preface — where he describes how the Maithili 'dalan' (gathering place) atmosphere was recreated in barrack conversations among soldiers from Mithila — is precisely Bhabha's 'third space': a cultural production that is neither metropolitan Hindi nor provincial Maithili but a new formation emerging from displacement.

Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's formulation 'Can the Subaltern Speak?' (1988) resonates powerfully with the cultural project of the entire book. The subjects of Jha's essays — Rajanandan Lal Das, Ravindra Thakur, Premlata Mishra, the Mithila Student Union activists — are precisely the subalterns of the Maithili literary system: individuals who laboured for the language without institutional support, without Sahitya Akademi recognition, without publication in the mainstream Hindi-English literary market. Jha's essays perform the counter-archival work Spivak identifies as necessary: they inscribe into the record subjects who would otherwise be epistemically invisible.

The essay on Ram Bhorosa Padi 'Bhramar' and his novel Gharmuha — a novel about the Madheshi political movement in Nepal — explicitly engages postcolonial questions: the 'Madheshi' identity of Terai Maithili-speakers in Nepal is itself a postcolonial formation, the product of the border drawn between India and Nepal by colonial cartography. Jha's analysis of the novel as a document of both political movement and social harmony is precisely the kind of reading Bhabha encourages: attending to ambivalence and hybridity rather than to simple resistance narratives.

## 4.3 Subaltern Studies: Ranajit Guha and the Archive

Ranajit Guha's founding essay for the Subaltern Studies collective ('On Some Aspects of the Historiography of Colonial India,' 1982) argues that colonial and nationalist historiography systematically excludes the subaltern from historical agency. The subaltern appears in the archive only as object of elite discourse. Jha's critical project is, in this framework, a counter-archival intervention: by writing detailed appreciation essays on living but unrecognised cultural workers, he inserts them into the literary archive as agents rather than objects.

The essay on the Mithila Students Union ('Ghataatop Anhaariya me Ummiidak Kiran' — 'A Ray of Hope in the Dense Darkness') is paradigmatic in this regard. Student organizations, specifically those of subaltern and lower-caste Maithili communities, have been almost entirely absent from mainstream Maithili literary history. Jha's essay argues that the MSU represents a democratic energy that the established literary institutions cannot generate — a Gramscian

'organic intellectual' formation from below. His praise for the MSU is critically calibrated: he acknowledges the organizational challenges and the risk of political co-option, while insisting on the movement's literary-cultural significance.

## 4.4 Reader-Response Theory: Iser, Fish, and the Reading Event

Wolfgang Iser (The Act of Reading, 1978) and Stanley Fish (Is There a Text in This Class?, 1980) locate meaning not in the text but in the transaction between text and reader, in the 'reading event.' Jha's entire critical stance is reader-response in orientation: the preface explicitly identifies him as a paathak (reader) rather than a writer, and each essay recounts not an abstract textual analysis but a specific, datable reading event — a conversation with Rajanandan Lal Das in 1987, reading Ashok's stories in the Videha archive, receiving a copy of Ravindra Thakur's songbook through his father.

This autobiographical reader-response mode has a specific political function in the Maithili context: it democratizes criticism. Academic Maithili criticism has been largely the province of university-employed professors and Sahitya Akademi-affiliated scholars. Jha's criticism comes from an Air Force technician, an LIC insurance officer — a demonstration that literary sensibility is not the monopoly of the credentialed professional. This is, in Stanley Fish's terms, an intervention in the 'interpretive community': Jha is asserting the validity of a non-academic interpretive community grounded in ordinary reader experience.

## 4.5 Marxist and Cultural Materialist Analysis

Raymond Williams's concept of 'structures of feeling' (Marxism and Literature, 1977) — the pre-reflective, lived experience of a cultural moment that literature captures before it crystallizes into explicit ideology — illuminates the deepest layer of Jha's criticism. The essays repeatedly gesture toward a structure of feeling that has no adequate name in Maithili literary discourse: the mixture of pride, grief, helplessness, and stubborn hopefulness that characterizes the lived experience of committed Maithili cultural workers in the twenty-first century. The phrase 'jatbe bujhlanhu tatbe likhlanhu' is precisely a naming of this structure of feeling: the writing is constrained by the understanding, and the understanding is constrained by what it is possible to know from a position of marginality.

Terry Eagleton's argument (Criticism and Ideology, 1976) that literary criticism is always already ideological — always in the service of some social formation

— applies to Jha's work with full force. His criticism is consciously in the service of the Videha Parallel Literature Movement's democratic, anti-canonical project. But unlike much ideologically committed criticism, Jha's work does not sacrifice critical discrimination to programmatic loyalty: the Samay-Saal essay shows him capable of identifying the weaknesses of a journal he clearly admires.

# V. Navya-Nyāya Epistemological Analysis

## 5.1 Gaṅgeśa's Framework: Pramāṇa and Vyāpti

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (c. 1300-1360 CE, Mithilā) — whose birthplace Nawadadhi in Madhubani district is approximately one hundred kilometres from Jha's ancestral village Yajuar in Muzaffarpur — developed in the Tattvacintāmaṇi the most rigorous formal epistemology in medieval world philosophy. His central achievement was the rigorous analysis of the conditions for valid cognition (pramāṇa) — particularly anumāna (inference) and its operative principle, vyāpti (invariable concomitance, pervasion).

Navya-Nyāya analysis of a text asks: what are the valid cognitive claims being made? On what pramāṇa (perceptual, inferential, analogical, testimonial) do these claims rest? What is the vyāpti (if A, then always B) underlying each evaluative judgment? And is that vyāpti itself well-founded, or does it conceal a hetvābhāsa (logical fallacy)?

## 5.2 Jha's Epistemology of Criticism: Pratyakṣa as Foundation

Jha's most fundamental epistemological commitment is to pratyakṣa (direct perception) as the primary pramāṇa for literary evaluation. His judgments are grounded in direct experience: 'I have been reading Karnaamrit since 1987' (of Rajanandan Lal Das); 'I have seen Ravindra Thakur perform ten to fifteen times' (of the lyricist); 'I downloaded and read Ashok's stories from the Videha archive last night' (of the fiction writer). This is a systematic privileging of the perceiver's own cognitive history over the śabda-pramāṇa (testimonial authority) of institutional criticism.

From a Navya-Nyāya standpoint, Jha's pratyakṣa-grounded criticism has both strength and limitation. The strength is epistemic directness: the claim 'this song moved me to tears fifteen times' is a robust pratyakṣa claim that is harder to contest than 'this is a great song' (which requires the unstated vyāpti 'great songs move people to tears'). The limitation is that pratyakṣa is inherently particular: it grounds claims about the perceiver's experience, not claims about the text's objective properties.

## 5.3 Vyāpti Analysis: The Underlying Invariable Concomitances

Jha's critical essays operate through several implicit vyāptis (if-then structures) that can be extracted and examined:

> *Vyāpti 1: Genuine Maithili cultural contribution → absence of institutional recognition (and vice versa: institutional recognition → suspect motivation)*

This is the deepest and most ideologically loaded vyāpti in the book. It reflects the Videha movement's counter-canonical epistemology. In Navya-Nyāya terms, this vyāpti risks becoming an atīvyāpti (over-wide pervasion) — it would make all institutional recognition automatically suspect. Jha's own essay on Gajendra Thakur partially corrects this: he praises Thakur as a genuine servant precisely because his institutional recognition (the Videha Samman itself) was self-created rather than externally bestowed. The distinction, however, requires clearer articulation than Jha provides.

> *Vyāpti 2: Sustained commitment over time → literary value (time-tested contribution is better contribution)*

This vyāpti is more defensible. Jha repeatedly invokes longevity of commitment as a criterion: Rajanandan Lal Das worked for Maithili for thirty-five years; Ravindra Thakur composed Maithili songs across five decades; Ram Bhorosa Padi 'Bhramar' has served Maithili for nearly five decades from Nepal. In Navya-Nyāya terms, the vyāpti 'sustained commitment → quality' is a probabilistic rather than universal claim — there are counter-examples (sustained mediocrity). But Jha correctly uses it as a heuristic, not as a logical necessity.

> *Vyāpti 3: Personal witness → valid critical testimony (having met someone → authorized to evaluate their contribution)*

This is Jha's most distinctive epistemological claim and the most problematic from a strict Navya-Nyāya standpoint. The claim is that having personally met Rajanandan Lal Das in 1987 authorizes a valid critical judgment about Das's contribution. In Navya-Nyāya terms, this confuses the pramāṇa for a psychological fact (having met someone produces certain feelings) with the pramāṇa for an evaluative claim (the person's work has such-and-such literary value). The meeting establishes the vivid emotional reality of the encounter; it does not establish the quality of the work independently of that encounter.

However, Jha himself partially acknowledges this when he says his essays are 'aloochana-sameeksha' (criticism-reviews) but that readers should judge for themselves. This epistemic humility is consistent with the Navya-Nyāya recognition that criticism is inference (anumāna), not perception (pratyakṣa), and that inference can be fallible.

## 5.4 Hetvābhāsa: The Fallacies of Canonical Criticism

Jha's implicit critique of mainstream Maithili criticism — its tendency to praise the critic's own circle and ignore the rest — is, in Navya-Nyāya terms, a diagnosis of hetvābhāsa (fallacious reasoning). The fallacy identified is savyabhicāra (irregular concomitance): the mainstream critic's vyāpti 'literary merit → Sahitya Akademi recognition' is violated by countless counter-instances, but the fallacy is maintained because the selection committee is itself constituted by those who have already been recognized. This is the self-referential epistemological circle that the Videha movement — and Jha's criticism within it — tries to break open.

The title's epistemological claim — 'as much as I understood, so much I wrote' — is in Navya-Nyāya terms a statement of epistemic limitation (jñānasya sīmā) that is itself a pramāṇa claim: the claim that honest epistemic limitation is more valuable than false certainty. Gaṅgeśa's own Tattvacintāmaṇi proceeds through a similar acknowledgment of the limits of each previous analysis before proposing its own refinement. Jha's title, consciously or not, places him in this tradition of calibrated epistemic modesty.

## 5.5 Pakṣatā and the Subject of Maithili Criticism

In Navya-Nyāya, pakṣatā refers to the property (dharma) that is attributed to the subject (pakṣa) in an inferential claim. A central Navya-Nyāya debate concerns the conditions under which a subject can be a valid pakṣa for a given inference. Applied to Jha's criticism: the 'subject' of each essay (Rajanandan Lal Das, Ravindra Thakur, etc.) must have the relevant properties to be a valid subject of the claim being made.

One of Jha's most important epistemological contributions is his insistence on the correct identification of pakṣa. He explicitly resists the mainstream practice of evaluating a person's literary contribution in abstraction from their institutional and biographical situation. For Rajanandan Lal Das, the correct pakṣa is not 'the literary canon of Maithili' but 'the living infrastructure of Maithili distribution networks' — the pakṣa for which Das is uniquely qualified. By correctly identifying the pakṣa, Jha avoids the atīvyāpti that would result from comparing Das to, say, a Sahitya Akademi awardee on the same terms.

# VI. Genre, Style, and Linguistic Character of the Essays

## 6.1 The Essay Form in Maithili

The literary essay (nibandha or aalekh) in Maithili has a relatively thin history compared to poetry and fiction. The Videha Parallel Literature Movement has been one of the primary vehicles for developing the Maithili essay as a sustained critical form. Jha's essays belong to a specific sub-genre: the critical portrait or 'parichay-nibandha' (introduction-essay), a hybrid form that combines biographical narrative, textual analysis, and personal testimony.

Within Indian literary history, this form is closest to the 'vyakti-chitran' (character-portrait) tradition of Hindi and Bengali criticism, and to the English tradition of the 'literary portrait' from Samuel Johnson's Lives of the Poets to Virginia Woolf's essays in The Common Reader. The connecting thread is the insistence that literary value is inseparable from the human life that produces it — a resistance to the formalist's tendency to abstract the text from its biographical conditions.

## 6.2 Linguistic Register

Jha writes in a distinctively modern, conversational Maithili — far from both the Brahminical Sanskrit-inflected Maithili of traditional pandits and the heavily Hindi-influenced 'practical Maithili' that the Videha movement criticizes. His sentences are typically medium-length, paratactic, and direct. He uses idiomatic Maithili expressions that ground the writing in vernacular authenticity: 'yatha naam, tatha kaam' (as the name, so the work) for the essay on Sagar Ji; 'succha sevak' (genuine servant) for Gajendra Thakur; 'van main aami' (a one-man army) for Rajanandan Lal Das.

This idiomatic richness is precisely what Kshemendra's auchitya demands: the style is appropriate to the subject. Jha does not write about folk musicians and grassroots cultural workers in the ornate, Sanskritized register of formal literary criticism. His language is calibrated to honor the democratic, non-elite subjects of his essays.

## 6.3 The Use of Direct Quotation

Jha's most technically accomplished critical move is his use of extended quotation as argument. In the essay on Ravindra Thakur, rather than arguing abstractly that the lyricist's songs are culturally significant, Jha quotes song

after song, allowing their accumulation to constitute the argument. This technique — borrowed from journalism but used here with literary discipline — demonstrates a sophisticated understanding of the dhvani principle: the songs resonate more powerfully in their juxtaposition than any analytical statement about them could.

The use of long quotation from Shardinduju Chaudhary's editorials in the Samay-Saal essay is equally effective: the ten editorial extracts (spanning 2003-2007) constitute a social history of Bihar and Mithila across a critical period. The method is essentially montage — letting the archive speak directly, with minimal editorial intervention. This is both a critical modesty and a critical strength.

# VII. Critical Assessment of Selected Essays

## 7.1 'Van Main Aami' — On Rajanandan Lal Das

This is the book's most personally vivid essay and its critical centrepiece. The phrase 'van main aami' (a one-man army) — which Jha reports Das's editorial column title as his dying wish for Maithili ('Maithili ke ekta aur Bhagiratha chaahi' — 'Maithili needs one more Bhagiratha') — is both a lament and a manifesto. Das emerges as the archetype of the Videha movement's ideal: total selflessness, zero institutional recognition, lifetime dedication. The essay succeeds in making Das's absence (he is deceased by the time of writing) palpable. The Navya-Nyāya principle of anupalabdhi (non-perception as a valid pramāṇa for absence) is here literarily enacted: the essay is the record of Das's felt absence from the current Maithili scene.

## 7.2 'Abaara Nahitan' — On Kedar Nath Chaudhary and the First Maithili Film

This essay is the book's most narratively accomplished piece. The near-suicide-by-drowning, the rescue by the smell of fried sweets, the meeting with 'Kauwali Babu' (an older mentor), the subsequent making of the first Maithili film 'Mamta Gaabay Geet' — the narrative has the coherence and surprise of good fiction. Jha's critical instinct is to let the story do the work: he introduces the film, provides context, and then largely steps back. The result is that the reader understands the film's significance not through assertion but through identification with the improbable chain of events that brought it into being. This is reader-response criticism at its most effective.

## 7.3 'Daidigan' — On Ashok's Short Story Collection

This is the book's most formally accomplished piece of literary criticism. Jha systematically works through all fifteen stories, identifying for each its central subject, its structural feature, and its thematic contribution to the collection's whole. His summary of the title story — in which an NRI returning to his ancestral village chooses to build a hospital rather than a temple — demonstrates genuine critical insight: he identifies the story's resolution as the key to the entire collection's vision of Maithili village society in transition. The essay demonstrates that Jha, when working with a text rather than a person, can sustain the critical distance that the essays on living persons sometimes lack.

## 7.4 'Samay-Saal ke Akanait' — On Shardinduju Chaudhary's Editorial Journal

This is the book's most intellectually honest essay. Jha praises Samay-Saal unreservedly as a journal of political and social consciousness while openly criticizing its recurring last-page content (the 'Latika' column) as inconsistent with the journal's dignity. The use of the word 'ashleelta' (obscenity) — mild but unmistakable — in relation to a journal he clearly admires and a figure he respects is the most critical gesture in the book. In the context of a Maithili critical tradition notorious for in-group protectionism, this is a notable act of critical honesty.

## 7.5 'Maithilik Succha Sevak' — On Gajendra Thakur

The essay on Gajendra Thakur, editor of Videha and the book's own publisher, is inevitably the most delicate in terms of critical independence. Jha navigates this with reasonable skill, focusing largely on the institutional contribution (the Videha eJournal, its archives, its role in Maithili literature) rather than on specific texts. The phrase 'succha sevak' is intended as the highest compliment; it is also, in the specific context of the Videha movement's counter-canonical project, a precise critical category: the servant who does not seek recognition is distinguished from the critic-politician who does. The essay's weakness is that it does not engage with any specific published work of Thakur's — an omission that leaves the critical claim insufficiently grounded.

# VIII. Significance, Limitations, and Place in the Maithili Critical Tradition

## 8.1 Significance

Jatbe Bujhlanhu Tatbe Likhlanhu is a significant contribution to Maithili literary criticism for four reasons. First, it represents the democratic extension of critical discourse to a non-academic, non-institutionally affiliated practitioner — validating the claim that literary criticism can be practiced from any social position, not only from the university. Second, it performs systematic counter-archival work, inscribing into the record cultural workers who would otherwise disappear from literary history. Third, it demonstrates the viability of the personal, testimony-based critical essay as a Maithili literary form. Fourth, and most consequentially, it constitutes a collective self-portrait of the Videha Parallel Literature Movement's human infrastructure — the people who have built the democratic Maithili literary project one small act at a time.

The book's publication itself is significant: it appeared under the Videha eJournal imprint (with Ashish Anchinhar as the initiating force) and is available on the Videha pothi (book) portal at www.videha.co.in — embodying the movement's principle that digital, open-access publication is the appropriate vehicle for democratic Maithili literature.

## 8.2 Limitations

The book has notable limitations. The essays on living persons (especially Gajendra Thakur, Narendra Jha) are not fully critically independent; the affective bonds of the Videha community are visible in the tonal register of these essays. The absence of any essay on a figure who is not already within the Videha-affiliated network raises the question of whether the book's 'democratic' critical agenda is in fact a community self-portrait — a parallel canon that is as self-enclosed as the mainstream canon it critiques.

The critical methodology is also uneven: the close reading of Ashok's Daidigan is not sustained across all essays. Several essays remain at the level of biographical appreciation without achieving the analytical distance that would make them fully critical. The essay on the Mithila Students Union, while politically important, is the least analytically precise: it operates through enthusiasm rather than argument.

From a Navya-Nyāya standpoint, the most persistent limitation is the conflation of pratyakṣa (personal experience) with anumāna (evaluative inference) — the

tendency to assert that 'I was moved by this' is equivalent to 'this is important.' The title's epistemic modesty ('as much as I understood') gestures toward this limitation but does not fully resolve it.

## 8.3 Place in Maithili Critical Tradition

In the longer history of Maithili literary criticism, Jha's essays belong to a tradition of practitioner-critics who have written about their contemporaries with passion and commitment: Ramanath Jha (as historical counterexample — canonical, exclusionary), Harimohan Jha (as the wit-essayist of social satire), and more recently the Videha movement critics themselves (Ashish Anchinhar, Gajendra Thakur). Jha's distinctive contribution to this tradition is the combination of personal testimony, social awareness, and critical honesty that marks the essays at their best.

The closest Western parallel is perhaps William Hazlitt's The Spirit of the Age (1825) — essays on the significant literary and intellectual figures of Hazlitt's own time, combining acute critical judgment with the vivid texture of personal acquaintance. Like Hazlitt, Jha is writing criticism as cultural history in real time, capturing a moment before it crystallizes into official record.

## IX. Conclusion: A Voice from the Margins of the Archive

Ajit Kumar Jha's Jatbe Bujhlanhu Tatbe Likhlanhu arrives — after thirty years of scattered publication — as an act of cultural testimony. It is the record of a Maithili reader who was shaped by the language's parallel tradition, who served that tradition through distribution and writing rather than through institutional position, and who found in the Videha eJournal a platform adequate to his critical vision. The book's modest title is its most truthful statement: this is a writer who wrote exactly as much as he understood, neither more nor less.

Read through the lens of Indian rasa theory, the book achieves karunarasa with disciplined restraint, never lapsing into sentiment while never pretending to false detachment. Read through Western postcolonial and subaltern theory, it performs the necessary work of counter-archiving the democratic margins of Maithili literary culture. Read through Navya-Nyāya epistemology, it demonstrates — with characteristic Mithilā directness — that the valid pramāṇa for literary criticism is not institutional authority but the honest record of a perceiving mind's encounter with cultural production.

The book's deepest claim is its title's claim: that writing and understanding are the same act, that the limit of the one is the limit of the other, and that this limitation is not a weakness but the ground of honesty. In an age of inflated critical claims and institutional self-promotion, this epistemological modesty is both a literary virtue and a political commitment.

जतबे बुझलहुँ ततबे लिखलहुँ — as much as I understood, so much I wrote. In the Maithili literary tradition, that has always been enough.

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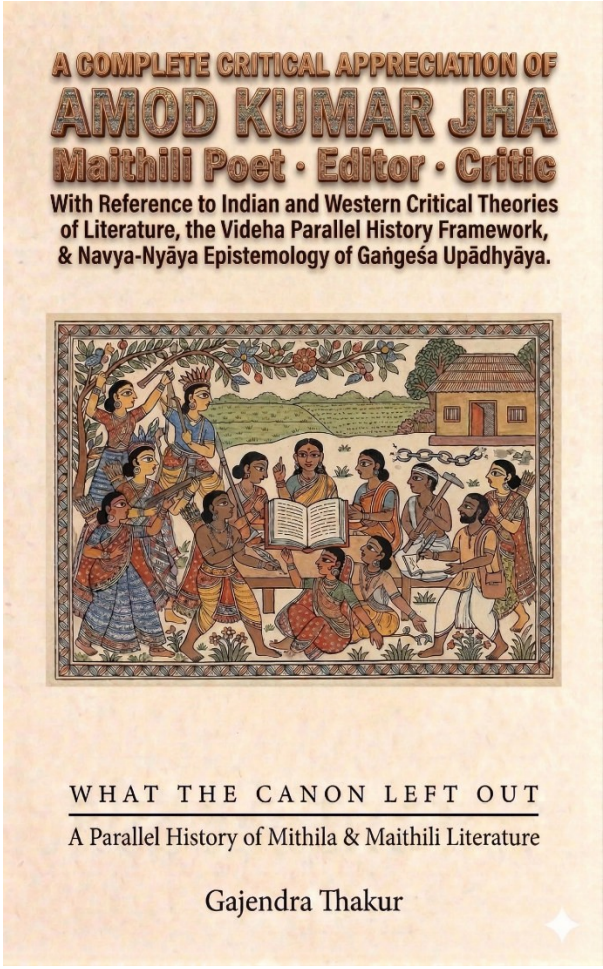
**LESSON 010 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**




# A COMPLETE CRITICAL APPRECIATION OF

# AMOD KUMAR JHA

*Maithili Poet · Editor · Critic*

*With Reference to Indian and Western Critical Theories of Literature,*
*the Videha Parallel History Framework, Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya,*
*and Bharata's Nāṭyaśāstra Rasa-Dhvani Aesthetics*

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## I. PREFATORY NOTE

Amod Kumar Jha is a Maithili poet, editor, and literary activist based in Kolkata whose first poetry collection, Bimbak Pathar (बिम्बक पथार — 'The Reflective Stone'), published in 2014 by Harekrishna Prakashan, Kolkata, announces the arrival of a sustained and socially engaged poetic voice in contemporary Maithili literature. The collection — introduced by a substantive critical preface by the eminent Maithili scholar and litterateur Prof. Dr. Basukīnātha Jhā — contains approximately ninety poems of varied length and register, ranging from brief epigrammatic pieces to extended lyric-meditations. The book has been archived on Videha (www.videha.co.in/pothi.htm), the first Maithili fortnightly e-journal (ISSN 2229-547X), edited by Gajendra Thakur, thereby entering the canon of the Videha Parallel History of Maithili literature.

This critical appreciation reads Bimbak Pathar through multiple interpretive frameworks: the Western critical tradition (from Aristotle and Longinus through Bakhtin, Spivak, Jameson, and Terry Eagleton); Indian aesthetic theory rooted in Bharata's Nāṭyaśāstra and Ānandavardhana's dhvani theory; the Navya-Nyāya epistemological framework of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (Mithila's own great logician); and the Videha Parallel History framework that documents non-mainstream Maithili literary voices. Through all these lenses, Bimbak Pathar emerges as a significant collection in modern Maithili poetry — wide in its social range, formally varied, politically alert, and humanistically committed.

## II. BIOGRAPHICAL INTRODUCTION: THE POET FROM MAUGALAHA TO KOLKATA

From the biographical note on the back cover of Bimbak Pathar, Amod Kumar Jha was born on 1 November 1968 in Maugalaha village, Post Misrauliya, Bhaya-Baburahi, Madhubani district — the heart of Mithila. His father was Svargīya Dayānātha Jhā; his mother Śrīmatī Baccī Devī; and his aunt (mausī) the late Muṃdrikā Devī — who is acknowledged as the one 'whose creative strength established his existence.' He was raised at Durgoli, Post Manpour, Bhaya Khirarhar, Madhubani. He received his education at Mādhyamik Uccavr Vidyālaya, Khirarhar; his intermediate and graduate degrees from Phool Deo Kumar Jha Mahavidyalaya, Andharathadi; his Maithili honours degree from Chandra Mishra Mahavidyalaya, Darbhanga; and his MA in Maithili from Patna University, Patna. He has cleared both the National Eligibility Test (NET) and Bihar Eligibility Test (BET).

His published works include: (1) Bimbak Pathar — Kavitā-Saṃgraha (poetry collection, 2014); (2) Kolakātā: Maithilī Kavitā — a co-edited anthology of Maithili poetry from Kolkata; (3) Ādhunik Maithilī Kavitā Daśā o Dṛṣṭi — a critical and editorial volume on the state and vision of modern Maithili poetry. He has also published extensively in journals, magazines, and memorials. His current address is New Gariya, Police Para, near Ashram, Kolkata-152.

Several elements of Jha's biography are literarily significant. The migration from rural Madhubani to Kolkata — the city that Maithili scholars call 'the second Mithila' because of its large diaspora community — is a defining arc of contemporary Maithili cultural production. Jha's academic grounding in Maithili (MA from Patna University, NET, BET) gives his poetry an unusually informed relationship with the literary tradition from within which he writes. His editorial work (the Kolkata anthology, the critical volume on modern Maithili poetry) positions him as a critic-poet in the double register of the engaged intellectual.

## III. THE TITLE AND THE COLLECTION: BIMBAK PATHAR — MEANING AND PROGRAMME

### 3.1 The Title: Bimba, Bimbak, Pathar

The title Bimbak Pathar is in Maithili and requires semantic unpacking. Bimba (बिम्ब) is a Sanskrit term meaning 'image,' 'reflection,' 'reflection in a mirror or water' — it is the standard term in Indian aesthetics for the image or mental impression formed in the mind by poetic language. In the alaṃkāra (figure of speech) tradition, bimba is specifically the primary term of a comparison, the thing compared. The adjectival form bimbak means 'of/relating to bimba/image/reflection.' Pathar in Maithili means 'stone' or 'rock.' The compound 'Bimbak Pathar' thus means literally 'the Stone of Images' or 'the Reflective Stone' — a stone that holds reflections, that retains impressions, that registers the impress of what has been.

As Prof. Dr. Basukīnātha Jhā clarifies in his preface ('Bimbak Pathar: Śābdak Sahakār' — 'Bimbak Pathar: The Collaboration of Words'), the title signals Jha's aesthetic programme: each poem is a stone surface upon which the images of contemporary social reality have been impressed. The bimba/reflection theory of Indian aesthetics, richly discussed in both the alaṃkāra and dhvani traditions, is Jha's self-announced critical framework. Jhā's preface explicitly engages with the Western concept of 'reflection' (English word used) and its transformation into the Indian aesthetic framework

of bimba, noting that image theory has been extensively discussed in Western criticism too and that bimba must be distinguished from mere illustration — it is the deep, socially engaged resonant image that the poet creates.

### 3.2 The Preface by Prof. Dr. Basukīnātha Jhā: A Critical Framework

The preface by Basukīnātha Jhā is itself a substantial critical text, offering a framework for reading the collection. Several key arguments emerge: First, the preface situates Jha's poetry within the intellectual context of the 19th-20th century: the era of social reform, development, scientific progress — an age of 'janaváda, gīt, navgīt, ghazal' forms moving toward post-modernism, with humanist currents present throughout. Second, it diagnoses a contemporary crisis in poetry: that words are losing their connection to lived feeling, becoming mere 'play of words' (śabda-khelauna), with the result that poems need 'protection and preservation' from mere formalism. Third, it celebrates Jha's achievement: each poem in the collection offers a genuine social vision; the language is distinctively Jha's own, with the colloquial Maithili idiom ('gobar chāuraka ḍhakiyā nāhit' — 'covering dung with chaff') used naturally and to great effect.

Jhā's critical vocabulary in the preface is revealing: he uses terms from both Indian aesthetics (bimba, alankār, dhvani, rasa) and implicitly from Western criticism (the 'reflection' concept, references to contemporary social and political life). The preface functions as a critical manifesto for the collection's programme: poetry must be socially rooted, experientially true, linguistically distinctive, and must achieve that resonance (hṛdaye jhaṃkār — 'resonance in the heart') that constitutes its highest achievement.

## IV. SURVEY OF THE POEMS: THEMES, STRUCTURE, AND RANGE

Bimbak Pathar contains approximately ninety poems across approximately ninety-six pages. The poems are arranged neither chronologically nor topically but in a sequence that creates thematic resonances and contrasts. The table of contents reveals the extraordinary thematic range: 'Āśā Bharal Muskī' (Hope-filled Smile), 'Ṭāṃgal Mon' (Hanging/Suspended Mind), 'Śaharakā Gāch' (City Tree), 'Katahu Pravāsī Katahu Pardeśī' (Somewhere a Migrant, Somewhere a Stranger), 'Hmarā Azurak Bhāṣā' (Our Motherless/Stepmother Language), 'Mukhaūṭā' (Mask), 'Ṭūṭit Rahel Saṃvedanāk Ḍori' (The Breaking Thread of Feeling), 'Goṃdhī Āb Katṛ?' (Gandhi, Come Now?), 'Mahānagar' (Metropolis), 'Talāk' (Divorce/Triple Talaq), 'Maryādāk Pratīk — Pākaṛi Gāch' (Symbol of Dignity — The Pakad Tree), 'Sapnā' (Dream), 'Bhūt-Vartamān-Bhaviṣya' (Past-Present-Future),

'Hantā' (The Killer/Alas), 'Adbhut Vikāsak Rastā' (The Strange Path of Development), 'Ḍomī' (The Dhobi Woman), 'Kivi: Kivi Nihi Thik Harvāha' (The Poet: Is the Poet Not Truly a Ploughman?), 'Śṛṃgārak Ek Upādān Nārī' (Woman as Mere Ingredient of Śṛṃgāra), and many others.

The poems vary in form from very short epigrammatic pieces (the 'Vākīl'/'Hākim' sequence, each only four to six lines) to extended lyric meditations of two or more pages ('Apiyārī', 'Chhoṭgar Samācār', 'Kathahu Pravāsī Katahu Pardeśī'). Most poems are free verse (chandamukta), without rhyme, employing the natural rhythms of spoken Maithili. A few poems have internal refrains or anaphoric structures (notably 'Kavitā me Becainī' with its triple refrain 'Hamar Āṃkhi / Hamar Āṃkhi / Hamar Āṃkhi' — 'Our Eyes / Our Eyes / Our Eyes'). The visual layout on the page — each line beginning flush left, short lines, generous white space — reflects a free-verse tradition that is comfortable with brevity and implication.

## V. THEMATIC ANALYSIS

### 5.1 Migration, Diaspora, and the Loss of Roots

The migration of Maithili speakers from rural Mithila to Kolkata and other cities is perhaps the most pervasive theme of Bimbak Pathar. The poem 'Katahu Pravāsī Katahu Pardeśī' ('Somewhere a Migrant, Somewhere a Stranger') is the collection's most sustained meditation on this condition. The migrant figure — unable to return home, not fully belonging to the city, marked by the awareness of difference — is developed through specific Maithili social images: the man who has no voter card, no ration card in the city; whose mother does not know what has happened to him; who has been away for twenty years but finds no trace of himself in either location.

*[Katahu Pravāsī Katahu Pardeśī]*

*Hamrā nahi sujhait achi*

*gām phurābāk bāṭa*

*gun-dhun bhel mati chiṃchrū jakāṃ*

*mālik'k adbhutiyā bhel rhai chī*

*(We cannot find our way back to the village /*

*our minds have become rat-like confused /*

*we have become the strange property of the master)*

The poem 'Śaharakā Gāch' ('City Tree') develops the migrant's predicament through the figure of a tree — planted at the city's crossroads, its familiar birds gone, standing alone in the urban environment, identified with the unemployed youth also standing at the crossroad in despair. This is one of the collection's finest short poems, achieving through objective correlative what a direct statement of alienation could not.

**5.2 The Mother Tongue at Risk: 'Hamrā Azurak Bhāṣā'**

The poem 'Hamrā Azurak Bhāṣā' ('Our Stepmother Language' or 'Our Language Without a Mother') is among the collection's most politically charged pieces. It diagnoses the condition of Maithili in the contemporary moment — a language that has lost its home, that holds conferences in cities but is not understood by its own Mithila community, that invokes Vidyapati but cannot find its own speakers, that asks whether anyone remembers the ballad of Raja Lorika, the stories of Banthā Chamār, the devotional songs of the tradition.

*[Hamrā Azurak Bhāṣā]*

*Nij haī kakrō garaj*

*śahare azur me karai haī baṛakā-baṛakā pārṭī āū sammilan*

*gāma azur me hamrā suhūn ke*

*nij bujhī haī maithil*

*(No one's concern is truly there /*

*Big parties and conferences in city venues /*

*In our villages, nobody hears us /*

*The Maithil does not understand his own language)*

The poem's devastating final lines — 'Dekhiyaun ne chīni letai kiyō / Hamrā azurak bhāṣā / kakar bāpak din haī / Sira lebaī vā sira kaṭā debai' — translate roughly as 'Look — who is taking away / our motherless language / Whose father's day is this / Cut off the head or give the head.' This is a call to cultural accountability that does not flinch from the difficult question: who is responsible for the erosion of Maithili?

**5.3 Political Critique and the Satirical Mode**

A substantial cluster of poems constitutes what might be called Bimbak Pathar's satirical-political portfolio. The poem 'Adbhut Vikāsak Rastā' (The Strange Path of Development) is a precise and devastating critique of

development discourse in contemporary India — where mobile phones and Facebook replace human connection, where 'progress' means Uttarakhand floods and Kashmir dam-breaks. 'Goṃdhī Āb Katṛ?' (Gandhi, Come Now?) asks Gandhi to return to a world where industrialisation has destroyed Indian villages, where multinational relations reduce people to economic transactions, where young people are caught between Indian roots and American modernity.

The poem 'Apiyārī' is a satirical masterpiece: a long narrative poem about a politician who promises a factory on 324 acres of land, whose son's position requires bribes, whose visit consists of being garlanded with milk and flowers while extracting political promises. The Maithili idiom is rich and specific — 'pāco aṃgurī ghī me / dunu beṭā kumār' (all five fingers in ghee / both sons safe) — a proverbial expression of complete corruption perfectly deployed.

### 5.4 Women's Condition: From 'Śṛṃgārak Ek Upādān Nārī' to 'Ḍomī'

Jha's feminist critique ranges from the programmatic to the specific. 'Śṛṃgārak Ek Upādān Nārī' ('Woman as Mere Ingredient of Śṛṃgāra') is a sustained feminist analysis of the classical poetic tradition: the dominant tradition has used woman as an instrument of the erotic rasa rather than representing her as a subject of her own experience. The poem explicitly names 'Rājakamal' (Rajkamal Chaudhary, the Maithili modernist writer) as someone whose experience has confirmed this reduction — positioning woman as decoration, not agent.

The poem 'Ḍomī' (about a woman of the Dhobi/washerwoman community) is one of the collection's finest social portraits. The Ḍomī figure comes alive through specific detail — working before dawn, learning to stitch in Konkan (from Punjab/Maharashtra skilled workers), pulling a rickshaw, navigating the indignity of having her INDIRA AWAS house claim cut from the mukhiya's list after twenty years — a portrait of systemic failure experienced by a specific, named social type.

### 5.5 Communal Harmony and the Godhra Memory

The poem 'Smṛtik Aṃk Me Godharā' (Godhra in the Register of Memory) is a quietly devastating account of communal violence: a neighbourhood where a mosque and a temple stand side by side, where all castes and religions live together, until one day — pilgrims burning in a train, people setting fire from different directions — the question remains unanswered: where did the mosque go, where did the temple go, where did Ram Lalla go? The poem does not take sides politically; it grieves the destruction of lived coexistence through an unnamed violence.

### 5.6 The Poet's Vocation: Reflexive Poems

Several of the collection's most original poems are reflexive — about the condition of poetry itself and the poet's place in society. 'Kivi: Kivi Nihi Thik Harvāha' (The Poet: Is the Poet Not Truly a Ploughman?) argues through sustained metaphor that the poet, like the farmer, must plough the ground of social reality with hard work — both are providers of life-giving sustenance, but neither is recognised. 'Bhūt-Vartamān-Bhaviṣya' (Past-Present-Future) articulates the poet's only aspiration: to awaken Maithili pride, preserve its language and literature, and prepare a strong young Maithili for the century ahead.

'Kavitā Me Becainī' (Restlessness in Poetry) — with its triple refrain 'Hamar āṃkhi / Hamar āṃkhi / Hamar āṃkhi' ('Our eyes / Our eyes / Our eyes') — meditates on how capitalist postmodernity ('pūṃjīvādī vyavasthā ā uttar-ādhuniktatāk ṭoṭakā') has taken the 'bimba' (image) away from poetry, colonising it for advertising and digitised spectacle.

## VI. CRITICAL APPRECIATION: WESTERN LITERARY THEORY

### 6.1 Marxist Criticism and the Literature of Social Engagement

Terry Eagleton's argument in Marxism and Literary Criticism (1976) that literature is not a passive reflection of social reality but an active production of meaning within social relations applies illuminatingly to Bimbak Pathar. Jha's poems do not merely reflect migration, corruption, or women's oppression — they actively constitute a counter-knowledge about these conditions, producing Maithili as the medium through which subaltern experience achieves articulate form. In Eagleton's terms, the collection's 'ideology' is humanist-progressive; its 'form' (free verse in spoken Maithili) is not neutral but expresses a commitment to accessibility and social inclusiveness.

### 6.2 Mikhail Bakhtin: Heteroglossia and the Dialogic Imagination

Bakhtin's concept of heteroglossia — the multi-voicedness inherent in language, where every utterance contains traces of other social voices — operates powerfully in Jha's poems. The poem 'Chhoṭgar Samācār' (Small News) is structurally dialogic: it layers the voices of politicians, mullahs, pandits, journalists, police, and ordinary citizens in a rapidly shifting sequence that enacts the cacophony of contemporary public discourse. The poem's devastating closure — 'aime kakrā kate māl bheṭataī rau bhajagār' (where does one find goods in this place) — allows the voices of power to expose themselves through their own unguarded speech.

### 6.3 Postcolonial Theory: Spivak and the Question of the Subaltern

Gayatri Spivak's question — 'Can the subaltern speak?' — is posed acutely by several poems in Bimbak Pathar. The poem 'Ḍomī' demonstrates that the Dhobi woman's capacity to speak is circumvented not by silence but by institutional exclusion: she speaks, she works, she navigates urban space — but the mukhiya cuts her name from the government list, the system acts as if she does not exist. This is the condition Spivak identifies: the subaltern is not voiceless but unheard within the institutional systems that should respond to her.

The poem 'Hamrā Azurak Bhāṣā' is the entire collection's most direct Spivakian text: Maithili itself is in the position of the subaltern language — the language that conferences are held about, but not held in; that elites celebrate but do not speak to their children.

### 6.4 Fredric Jameson: The Political Unconscious

Jameson's argument that all literary texts contain a 'political unconscious' — repressed or latent social content that the text's form both reveals and disguises — helps illuminate Bimbak Pathar's formal choices. The free verse form of the poems, with its refusal of classical metre or the decorative alaṃkāra tradition, is itself a political statement: it refuses the Brahminical, courtly literary aesthetic of classical Maithili in favour of the spoken idiom of the common person. The very choice of 'ṭheṭh' (indigenous, unrefined) Maithili words — 'gobar' (dung), 'bhūsī' (chaff), 'harjot' (plough) — as poetic diction is a challenge to the hegemony of Sanskritised literary Maithili.

### 6.5 Narrative Theory: Gerard Genette and the Poem as Narrative

Several of Bimbak Pathar's longer poems are structurally narrative — they tell stories rather than merely offering lyric reflection. 'Apiyārī' is essentially a narrative poem: it narrates the encounter between a constituents' delegation and their politician, with a fully developed plot arc, recognisable character types, and a sardonic denouement. Genette's distinction between histoire (story), récit (narrative), and narration (narrating act) illuminates how Jha's 'narrative poems' work: the narrating voice is that of the aggrieved citizen/witness, the récit is organised around the politician's promises and evasions, and the histoire is the permanent condition of rural neglect.

### 6.6 Longinus and the Sublime: Civic Grandeur in Bimbak Pathar

Longinus's Peri Hypsous (On the Sublime) argued that great literature must transport the reader through the experience of grandeur — moral,

emotional, or conceptual. The civic sublime of Bimbak Pathar is not found in landscape or cosmic imagery but in the dignity of the ordinary person. The poem 'Māṭi' (Soil/Earth) achieves this in six lines: 'Anything that was, is from this earth / anything that will remain, stays on this earth / Brahma on this earth / Vishnu on this earth / Mahesh also on this earth / The human form is therefore / all is from the earth / all is of the earth.' The reduction of the cosmic hierarchy to the materiality of soil is simultaneously an ecological and a humanist statement of sublime simplicity.

## VII. CRITICAL APPRECIATION: INDIAN AESTHETICS, NĀṬYAŚĀSTRA, AND RASA THEORY

### 7.1 Rasa Theory Applied to Bimbak Pathar

Bharata Muni's Nāṭyaśāstra identifies eight primary rasas that a literary work produces in the reader through the interaction of vibhāva (stimulus), anubhāva (response), and vyabhicāribhāva (transitory emotions). Bimbak Pathar's dominant rasas are:

**Karuṇa rasa (compassion/pathos):** The dominant rasa of the collection. Poems like 'Ḍomī', 'Āśā Bharal Muskī' (the stone-breaker woman whose only possession is a hope-filled smile), and 'Ṭāṃgal Mon' (the migrant worker running to catch the train with half-done work) produce sustained karuṇa — not sentimental pity but the engaged compassion of someone who has seen and borne witness.

**Raudra rasa (righteous anger):** The satirical-political poems — 'Goṃdhī Āb Katṛ?', 'Apiyārī', 'Khādhi', 'Gauṃāṃ Chaik Vakalel' — produce a controlled raudra: the anger of the citizen who sees the gap between democratic promise and oligarchic reality.

**Hāsya rasa (comic/ironic):** The satirical mode of several poems (notably 'Kavi-Goṣṭhī' — the poet's gathering — and 'Dāv-Peṃc') operates through bitter comedy. 'Kavi-Goṣṭhī' is a masterpiece of hāsya: a poets' gathering where the announcer is lost in his own importance, the audience vanishes before anyone can read, and the performers scatter like parliamentary members.

**Vīra rasa (heroic courage):** The poems of linguistic pride ('Hamrā Azurak Bhāṣā', 'Chhoṛi Diy Rastā Hamar') and of cultural assertion produce a subdued but genuine vīra — the hero who refuses to abandon the mother tongue even under pressure.

**Bībhatsa rasa (disgust):** The corruption poems deploy bībhatsa: the disgust at seeing democracy reduced to bribery, courts reduced to farce, language reduced to commodity.

### 7.2 Dhvani (Resonance) in Bimbak Pathar

Ānandavardhana's Dhvanyāloka argues that the greatest literary achievement lies not in what is stated but in what is suggested — the dhvani or resonant unstated meaning. Jha's best poems work precisely through dhvani. 'Śaharakā Gāch' does not state 'the migrant is as isolated as a tree in an alien city' — it shows the tree standing at the crossroad, its birds gone, its branches untouched, and places alongside it 'another figure' also standing there in despair. The identification is performed through proximity, not comparison — this is dhvani operating at its purest.

The poem 'Māṭi' (Soil) achieves dhvani in a different register: its explicit statement (all things come from and return to earth) resonates with the unstated implication that all hierarchies — caste, class, gender — are as temporary as the human body on the earth that will outlast it.

### 7.3 The Alaṃkāra Tradition and Bimbak Theory

The collection's very title announces its engagement with the alaṃkāra tradition's concept of bimba. In Indian poetics, bimba (the primary image in a comparison) and pratibimba (its reflection) are central to upamā (simile) and rūpaka (metaphor). Jha, following the critical framework established in Basukīnātha Jhā's preface, deploys bimba not as mere decoration but as the cognitive structure through which social reality becomes legible. The stone that holds reflections — bimbak pathar — is a meta-image for the poem itself: a hard surface that captures and preserves the image of the world that touches it.

### 7.4 Loka Dharma: Poetry in the Service of the Community

Bharata's Nāṭyaśāstra stipulates that literature must serve the dharma of the loka — the people. Bimbak Pathar is explicitly committed to loka dharma: it addresses the concerns of the Maithili-speaking community across its full social range — the migrant worker, the Dhobi woman, the unemployed youth, the village facing corruption, the language facing erosion, the woman facing objectification in classical poetry. This is not a poetry of private self-cultivation but of social engagement — in precisely the terms that Bharata and the later tradition describe as loka dharma.

## VIII. NAVYA-NYĀYA EPISTEMOLOGY OF GAṄGEŚA UPĀDHYĀYA APPLIED TO BIMBAK PATHAR

### 8.1 Gaṅgeśa and Jha: Two Mithila Intellectuals

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (fl. 13th-14th century CE), the founder of the Navya-Nyāya school of Indian epistemology, was a native of Mithila — the very cultural heartland from which Amod Kumar Jha comes. Gaṅgeśa's Tattvacintāmaṇi ('Wish-Fulfilling Gem of Truth') established the most technically precise system of epistemological analysis in Indian philosophy. As documented in Gajendra Thakur's Parallel History of Maithili Literature and in Videha's coverage, Gaṅgeśa's own social biography was complex: he married outside the conventional Brahmin social order (a woman of the artisan community), an act that placed him on the social margins even as his intellectual achievement was beyond question. This structural parallel — the Mithila intellectual who works at the boundaries of the socially sanctioned — illuminates Jha's own position as a poet of the Maithili diaspora who challenges the conservative literary establishment.

### 8.2 The Four Pramāṇas Applied to Bimbak Pathar

Navya-Nyāya recognises four pramāṇas (valid sources of knowledge): pratyakṣa (direct perception), anumāna (inference), upamāna (analogy), and śabda (verbal testimony). Jha's poems operate through all four:

**Pratyakṣa (Direct Perception):** The poems rooted in direct observation — 'Ṭāṃgal Mon' (the migrant woman running to catch the train), 'Nocalī' (the backache noticed in a hotel room in Jaipur), 'Āśā Bharal Muskī' (the stone-breaking woman's smile in the heat) — ground their authority in witnessed experience. The poetic subject has seen, has felt, has been present. This is pratyakṣa as the foundation of poetic validity.

**Anumāna (Inference):** The diagnostic and critical poems — 'Adbhut Vikāsak Rastā', 'Phalā Mīṭh Vākīl Hākim' — move from observable symptoms (the politician's behaviour, the administrator's indifference) to inferred structural causes (systemic corruption, the class character of the state apparatus). This is anumāna: from the observed sign (liṃga) to the inferred cause (sādhya).

**Upamāna (Analogy):** The collection's core bimba/image strategy is upamāna — the comparison through which the unfamiliar or abstract becomes accessible. The city tree as analogue for the migrant; the soil as analogue for democracy; the pakaṛ tree as analogue for village dignity. Each of these is a carefully constructed upamāna that generates valid cognitive access to its subject.

**Śabda (Testimony):** The poems invoke the śabda of the Maithili tradition — Vidyapati, Lorika, Bhāmatī, Phuleśvarī, Ranī Kusumā — not as ornament but

as valid testimony about the depth and dignity of Maithili culture. The poem 'Chhoṛi Diy Rastā Hamar' explicitly invokes these testimonies as witness to what is being lost.

### 8.3 Vyāpti and the Universalising Move in Jha's Poetry

Navya-Nyāya's concept of vyāpti — the universal concomitance between a sign and its signified — is the logical structure that allows particular observations to ground general conclusions. Jha's poems consistently perform vyāpti: the particular Dhobi woman's story generates a universal claim about Dalit women's treatment by the bureaucratic system; the particular migrant worker's inability to find his way back grounds a universal claim about the rupture between village and city in contemporary India. This universalising move — from the witnessed particular to the structural general — is the epistemological core of committed social poetry.

### 8.4 Viśeṣya-Viśeṣaṇa-Saṃbandha: The Navya-Nyāya Language of Qualification

Gaṅgeśa's technical vocabulary for the structure of cognition — viśeṣya (the qualified, the locus), viśeṣaṇa (the qualifier, the property), and saṃbandha (the relation between them) — provides a precise tool for understanding Jha's image-making. In the poem 'Śaharakā Gāch': the tree (viśeṣya) is qualified by the absence of its birds (viśeṣaṇa), connected to the migrant's isolation (saṃbandha through proximity). Each image in the collection can be analysed as a viśeṣya-viśeṣaṇa-saṃbandha structure in which the qualifying element generates the meaning that could not have been stated directly.

## IX. THE VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY FRAMEWORK: AMOD KUMAR JHA'S PLACE

Gajendra Thakur's Videha (www.videha.co.in) — the first Maithili fortnightly e-journal (ISSN 2229-547X) — has developed what it calls a 'Parallel History of Mithila and Maithili Literature,' systematically documenting writers excluded from or marginalised by the Sahitya Akademi's conservative advisory structure. The Videha pothi (book) archive (www.videha.co.in/pothi.htm) has archived Bimbak Pathar, thereby including Jha within the Videha parallel canon.

Jha's position within the Videha parallel is distinctive. Unlike the farmer-poets (Jagdish Prasad Mandal, Ramdeo Prasad Mandal 'Jharudar'), Jha is an academically trained Maithili scholar (MA, NET, BET) — yet he writes from the margins of the mainstream literary establishment as a diaspora poet in Kolkata, outside the Bihar-based institutions. Unlike the scientist-writer

Yogendra Pathak Viyogi, he writes primarily in a social-critical lyric mode. His closest parallel within the Videha circle is perhaps Kumar Pawan — another poet-scholar of the middle generation working in the tradition of committed Maithili verse.

Within the Videha framework, Jha is significant as an example of the second generation of Maithili diaspora poets who bring both academic grounding and lived urban experience to their writing. His editorial work — the Kolkata Maithili poetry anthology and the critical volume on modern Maithili poetry — places him in the role of a Gramscian organic intellectual: not merely a creative artist but an organiser and theoriser of Maithili literary culture from within the diaspora.

## X. COMPARATIVE STUDY: AMOD KUMAR JHA AMONG MAITHILI POETS

### 10.1 Jha and Nagarjuna (Yatri): The People's Poetry Tradition

Nagarjuna (Vaidyanath Mishra, 1911-1998), writing as 'Yatri' in Maithili and 'Nagarjun' in Hindi, is the canonical figure of the Maithili people's poetry tradition. His Patrahin Nagna Gachh (Leafless Naked Tree) won the Sahitya Akademi Award. Jha inherits and extends the Nagarjuna tradition of politically engaged, accessible verse — but with crucial differences. Where Nagarjuna was a Maithil Brahmin who consciously crossed class and caste boundaries through political commitment and Buddhist conversion, Jha writes from within the diaspora as a practicing Maithili scholar. Where Nagarjuna's political poetry was shaped by Marxism and the JP Movement, Jha's is shaped by a humanist ethics closer to Gandhi (invoked directly in 'Goṃdhī Āb Katṛ?') and by the specific concerns of language preservation and diaspora identity.

### 10.2 Jha and Rajkamal Chaudhary: The Feminist Critique

The poem 'Śṛṃgārak Ek Upādān Nārī' directly and critically engages with Rajkamal Chaudhary (1929-1967), the controversial Maithili modernist who is widely regarded as the most important Maithili poet of the 20th century. Rajkamal's 'Maithilīk Agrabhāg' poetry used erotic imagery in ways that were celebrated by some critics as liberation from bourgeois moralism and criticised by others as exploitation of women's bodies for male aesthetic pleasure. Jha's poem takes the latter position: 'anubhav saṃ likhala rājakamal / puruṣ achi mahādhūrt / eṃdrik aślīl rūpme nārī kāvya śṛṃgārak upādān' ('from experience Rajkamal wrote / man is the great deceiver / in a sensory, vulgar form / woman in poetry is a mere ingredient of śṛṃgāra'). This is a bold critical move — Jha

directly criticises the tradition's most celebrated modernist from a feminist-humanist position.

### 10.3 Jha and Harimohan Jha: The Satirical Tradition

Harimohan Jha (1908-1984), author of Khattar Kakak Tarang (Khattar Kaka's Waves), established Maithili social satire as a major literary form. Jha's satirical poems — particularly 'Apiyārī', 'Dāv-Peṃc', 'Kavi-Goṣṭhī', and 'Chhoṭgar Samācār' — inherit and extend this satirical tradition. The difference is one of target and register: where Harimohan Jha satirised the internal contradictions of Maithil Brahmin orthodoxy from within, Jha's satire targets the political class, the administrative apparatus, and the literary establishment as external forces oppressing the community.

### 10.4 Jha and Jagdish Prasad Mandal: Subaltern Voices

Jagdish Prasad Mandal, the OBC farmer-writer who won the Sahitya Akademi Award 2021, writes in social realist prose fiction. Jha's 'Ḍomī' and 'Āśā Bharal Muskī' cover similar subaltern territory — the Dhobi woman, the stone-breaking labourer — in the lyric mode. Both writers are committed to representing voices that the classical Maithili tradition and the Sahitya Akademi structure have systematically excluded. The difference is generic: Mandal achieves documentary depth through the novel form; Jha achieves concentrated emotional and intellectual power through the lyric.

## XI. THE KOLKATA MAITHILI DIASPORA AND LITERARY PRODUCTION

Kolkata has historically been the most important centre of Maithili diaspora literary production outside Mithila itself. Journals such as Mithilā Darśan (Kolkata) have been primary venues for modern Maithili poetry and prose. The Maithili Sāhitya Saṃsthā and related organisations have organised events that have sustained a literary community in the city. The anthology Kolakātā: Maithilī Kavitā, which Jha co-edited, documents this tradition and his own role in sustaining it.

Jha's location in Kolkata gives his poetry a specific double vision: the city that the Maithili migrant inhabits is simultaneously the place from which the village is viewed with longing and grief, and the place from which the condition of Maithili culture and language in the homeland can be seen with critical distance. This double vision — insider/outsider, Mithila/Kolkata — is the structural condition of his poetic imagination and one source of its authority.

## XII. RECEPTION AND PUBLICATION HISTORY

Bimbak Pathar (2014, Harekrishna Prakashan, Kolkata) was introduced by Prof. Dr. Basukīnātha Jhā's substantial critical preface — a mark of significant literary recognition within the Maithili community. The preface is titled 'Bimbak Pathar: Śābdak Sahakār' ('Bimbak Pathar: The Collaboration of Words') and constitutes the most sustained critical engagement with the collection. The book is archived on Videha's pothi (book) archive, placing it within the canon of the Maithili parallel literary tradition. Jha has also edited two other Maithili volumes (the Kolkata poetry anthology and the critical volume on modern Maithili poetry), indicating both his literary standing and his role as a cultural organiser within the Maithili community.

## XIII. CONCLUSIONS: LITERARY SIGNIFICANCE AND LEGACY

Bimbak Pathar is a collection of genuine literary achievement and social significance. Its literary merits are multiple and can be identified across the critical frameworks applied in this appreciation:

**Formal range and competence:** The collection demonstrates mastery of free verse in Maithili, from the epigrammatic short poem to the extended lyric-narrative. The formal variety — short, sharp poems; extended social portraits; reflexive poems about poetry itself — gives the collection an architectural richness.

**Social breadth:** No other contemporary Maithili poetry collection known to this author covers as wide a range of social types and conditions: the migrant, the Dhobi woman, the stone-breaker, the corrupt politician, the compromised poet, the language under threat, the communal violence victim, the unemployed youth, the farmer displaced by globalisation.

**The bimba programme:** Jha's self-conscious deployment of the bimba/image theory — announced in the title and elaborated in the prefatory framework — gives the collection an intellectual coherence that distinguishes it from mere thematic anthology. The poems work through images that resonate, dhvani-fashion, with meanings beyond their explicit content.

**The Kolkata diaspora perspective:** Jha's double vision — Mithila roots, Kolkata location — gives his poetry a specific insight into the condition of Maithili culture and language that neither the Bihar-based writer nor the fully assimilated urban intellectual could achieve.

**Contribution to the Videha parallel tradition:** By being archived and celebrated by Videha, Bimbak Pathar enters the tradition of Maithili parallel literature that Gajendra Thakur has systematically documented — a tradition

that values social engagement, democratic literary values, and linguistic diversity over the conservative mainstream.

*Bimbak Pathar kavitā saṃgrahak kāvyakār Śrī Āmod Kumār Jhāk saphalatā ō yaśak uccatar sopāna satatā dṛḍhatāpūrvak pār karaitī rahi thi takrā kāmanā.* — Prof. Dr. Basukīnātha Jhā (concluding wish in his preface to Bimbak Pathar)

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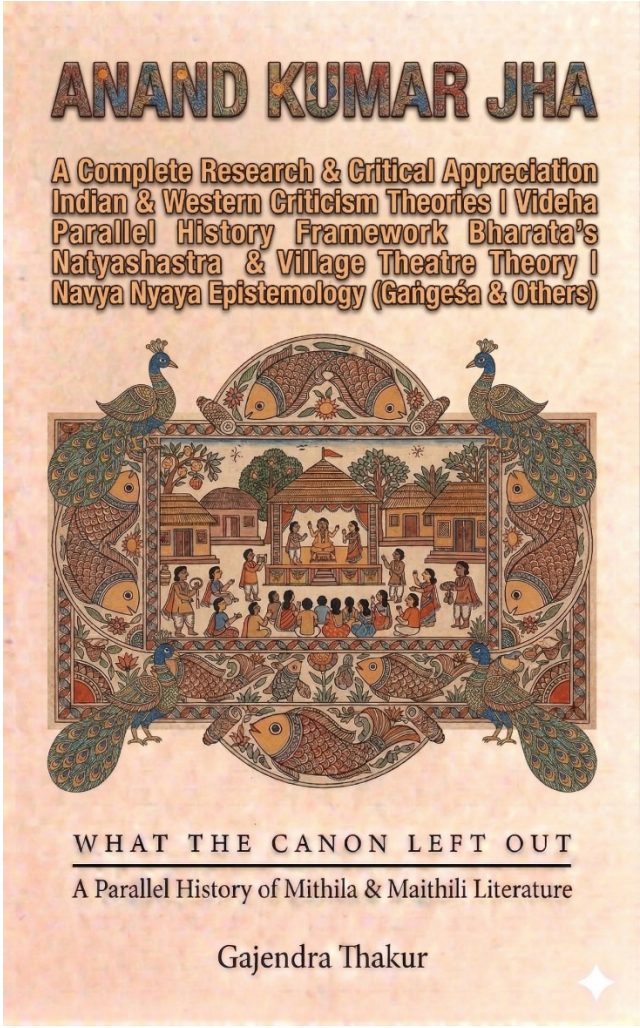
**LESSON 011 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**




# ANAND KUMAR JHA

*A Complete Research & Critical Appreciation*

Indian & Western Criticism Theories | Videha Parallel History Framework

Bharata's Natyashastra & Village Theatre Theory | Navya Nyaya Epistemology (Gaṅgeśa & Others)

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## 1. Introduction: Who Is Anand Kumar Jha?

Anand Kumar Jha is one of the most distinctive and socially committed voices in contemporary Maithili drama. Rooted in the village of Menhath (मेंहथ), Jhanjharpur, Madhubani district, Bihar — in the very heartland of Mithila civilisation — he represents a generation of playwrights who emerged from rural Mithila in the late twentieth century, carrying the concerns of ordinary families, unemployed youth, dowry victims, patriotic soldiers' families, and politically manipulated village communities onto the Maithili stage.

His plays — Takak Mol (टाकाक मोल, 2000), Kalah (कलह), Dhadhait Navki Kaniyank Lahas (धधाइत नवकी कनियाँक लहास, 2003), Hathat Parivartan (हठात् परिवर्तन), Badlait Samaj (बदलैत समाज), and Mukti Yatra (मुक्ति यात्रा, c. 2015-16) — have been performed repeatedly across Maithili-speaking regions, from village stages in Madhubani to diaspora stages in Kolkata. His play Hathat Parivartan won the prestigious Sahitya Akademi Youth Prize at the national level — Maithili's first such recognition for a young playwright in this period — establishing him as a significant force in Indian regional theatre.

The critical essay prefacing Mukti Yatra (written by Rinku Devi) situates Jha within the sweep of Maithili dramatic history: from Jyotirishwar Thakur's 'Dhurta Samagam' and Vidyapati's 'Manimanjari' through the modern tradition inaugurated by Jiwan Jha's 'Sundar Sanyog', to the contemporary playwrights named in Gajendra Thakur's Videha survey — including Mahendra Malangiya, Uday Narayan Singh 'Nachiketa', Usha Kiran Khan, Vibha Rani, and others — among whom Jha takes his place as a representative voice of the younger generation.

What distinguishes Jha's theatre is its uncompromising attachment to the lived reality of Mithila's rural and semi-urban social world: the economics of dowry, the psychology of joint-family conflict, the patriotic consciousness of military families, the corrupting influence of politics on village character, and — in his most recent and ambitious play — the intertwining of national security threats, women's liberation, and the moral crisis of modernity. His writing is the literature of the village stage, grounded in performability, clarity of social message, and direct emotional communication with a non-elite audience.

## 2. Biographical Context and the Making of a Playwright

The autobiographical note in Mukti Yatra, one of the most moving author's statements in contemporary Maithili literature, reveals the extraordinary personal cost at which Jha has maintained his commitment to dramatic writing. He grew up in Menhath village, Jhanjharpur, Madhubani, and moved to Kolkata for a period of work during which he wrote several of his early plays. The critical prefatory note confirms: 'Anand Kumar Jha is a representative playwright of the young generation. During his Kolkata residence he wrote many plays. Many of his plays have been successfully staged. In his desire to write purposeful drama, he never became complacent. He proved himself again and again in subject selection and stage presentation.'

A sequence of family crises — the death of his father (who had been the financial support for his publications), the mental illness of both younger brothers Trilok and Amarendra (which forced him to leave employment and return to the village), the sale of fields and orchards to meet expenses — created a twelve-year period during which no new play was published, even as village troupes across Mithila continued to stage and re-stage his earlier five plays. He writes: 'I have seen my father's passing in these difficult times, through whose tireless effort book publication was possible. Both younger brothers Trilok and Amarendra became mentally ill, for which I had to leave my job and stay in the village. Thereafter a severe economic crisis began. As a result, fields and orchards began to be sold, a chain that continues to this day.'

Through all this, his wife maintained a small bookshop in Jhanjharpur — a Maithili Book Centre — 'in the belief that one day this Maithili book centre's day will come.' The dedication in Dhadhait is addressed simply to his wife, Sri Rinku Anand, describing her as companion in his literary life. This background — the poverty and sacrifice that attend Maithili literary production outside institutional support systems — is essential context for understanding both the social urgency of his writing and his alignment with the Videha Parallel History project.

The publisher Sri Prabhakar Abhinay Samiti, Gandhwari — a village-based theatre group — staged the premiere of Dhadhait Navki Kaniyank Lahas on 12 October 2002 under the auspices of a Durga Puja celebration committee. This originary context — festival performance by an amateur village troupe, for a village audience — is the constitutive performative context for all of Jha's plays and determines their dramaturgy, language register, and social function.

His publishers — Prachi Prakashan (Menhath, Jhanjharpur), Dipali Prakashan (Howrah), and Navarambh Prakashan — are small regional publishers, many based in the diaspora Maithili community. His plays were priced at Rs. 30-35 per copy with print runs of 500-1,100 copies — modest figures that nonetheless represent significant reach within the Maithili-speaking community.

## 3. Overview of the Six Plays

### 3.1 Takak Mol (टाकाक मोल, 2000) — The Price of Money

Takak Mol (published September 2000, 1,100 copies, Rs. 30) is Jha's debut play and an anti-dowry drama set in the household of Garib Jha — a poor Brahmin father with five daughters and minimal land. The play opens with Prabha, the eldest unmarried daughter, performing devotional worship and singing: 'Being born a poor man's daughter, how much humiliation must I endure in the world.' The central dramatic conflict unfolds around the desperate search for a suitable groom who will not demand an excessive dowry, the manipulations of a marriage-broker (Dalal) and his assistant (Chela), and the courage of the young man Jivesh who refuses to be complicit in the dowry system.

Key characters include: Garib Jha (poor father, 60), Sumitra (mother), Prabha (the heroine, college student), Gunanand (wise village elder), Dalal (marriage broker), and Jivesh (Garib's son forced to be a buffalo-herder instead of attending school because his father cannot afford both daughters' weddings and son's education). The play's dramatic irony — that the family's economic resources are entirely consumed by dowry demands, leaving no funds for the son's education — encodes a precise social-economic critique of the systemic irrationality of the dowry economy.

In the preface, Jha writes: 'Although many compositions on the dowry system have already come from the pen of scholars in Maithili, the day this society will find liberation from the cancer of dowry is receding further. After seeing all this, my heart could not stop itself from opposing this, and I tried to highlight this event in a new way and at the same time tried to advise the young men and women of the new generation to come forward openly.'

## 3.2 Dhadhait Navki Kaniyank Lahas (2003) — The Burning Bride

Published on Janaki Navami, 11 May 2003 (500 copies, Rs. 35), this play takes its title — 'The Smouldering Corpse of the New Bride' — directly from the horrific social reality of bride-burning: the murder of brides, usually by fire, when their dowry is deemed insufficient by the groom's family. The play was first staged by Sri Prabhakar Abhinay Samiti, Gandhwari, on 12 October 2002. Characters include Mantreshwar, Sameer, Shobhan, Ramlal, Shyamalakant, Doctor, Ritesh, Sushila, and Shikha. The play features a central female character Shikha in conversation with Sameer in an emotionally charged domestic situation. In the preface Jha acknowledges his debts to Dr. Dhanakar Thakur, Sri Ashok Ji, Sri Kulachandra Mishra, and others whose encouragement sustained his writing.

The essay on drama prefacing this volume is a significant theoretical statement: 'Drama is a visual poem (drishyakavya). It is considered the most powerful form of literature. All categories of audience are directly affected by it simultaneously. Through drama, the country, society, and individual circumstances and problems are brought before the audience face to face... The work that drama does in awakening the dormant consciousness of human beings collectively, no other literary form can do as effectively. At the level of revolution, drama is the most successful and simple literary form for bringing public consciousness.'

## 3.3 Kalah (कलह) — Family Discord

Kalah is subtitled 'Maithili Family Drama depicting the swelling pain of today's unemployed youth and young women entangled in current family problems.' Set in the 'Akash' household (literally 'Sky' — a domestic space with aspiration and turbulence), the play centres on Aarti (the daughter-in-law), Sumitra (the mother-in-law), Sureshwar (the father-in-law), and Akash (the husband). The opening scene depicts Aarti resting on a bed listening to the radio when Sumitra enters in an angry mood. The conflict escalates from domestic bickering to generational accusation to physical violence — Akash strikes Aarti when he believes she has dishonoured his parents — and is mediated by the intervention of Lutan Kaka, an elderly neighbour. The play explicitly situates domestic violence within unemployment: Akash's failure to earn money is the structural cause of his insecurity and aggression.

## 3.4 Hathat Parivartan (हठात् परिवर्तन) — Sudden Change

Winner of the All-India Sahitya Akademi First Youth Prize for Maithili drama, Hathat Parivartan is set in the haveli (mansion) of retired Brigadier Krishnachandra Pratap — a household defined by military honour, national pride, and sacrifice. The Pratap family's elder son Gopal Chandra Pratap serves as an Army Commander on the border. The dramatic conflict unfolds around the younger son Giridhar — an alcoholic, irresponsible youth — whose behaviour brings shame on the family's proud military legacy. The play features a complex family structure: Saraswati (wife/mother), Ranjana (daughter-in-law), Rohan (grandson), Shailini, Sajendra (uncle figure), and other characters. The play moves between scenes of patriotic exhortation and scenes of domestic comedy and pathos, contrasting the sacrificial ethic of military families with the hedonistic escapism of the urban-educated youth.

The announcement (Ghoshana) that opens the play frames the Pratap family's haveli as 'the immortal heritage of patriotism and goodwill... every stone of which seems to tell the story of sacrifice and renunciation, to sing the epic of valor and heroism.' This patriotic framing connects the play to the broader genre of nationalist social drama that Bharata's Natyashastra would classify under Sattvati Vritti (the heroic-noble dramatic style).

## 3.5 Badlait Samaj (बदलैत समाज) — Changing Society

Badlait Samaj is subtitled 'Social drama based on character-assassination attempts driven by political motives.' Its cast includes: Ghuran (Avdhesh's father, 60), Bhajendra (Deepak's father, 60), Avdhesh (sick young man, 25), Deepak (ideal young man, 25), Mandun (cunning villager, 50), Shikhar (sycophantic villager, 35), Netaji (politician, 50), Somen (lackey, 35), Vijendra (honest young villager, 30), Inspector (police, 37), Abhishek (Avdhesh's brother, 12). The play focuses on the intersection of illness, village politics, and character assassination. The bedridden young man Avdhesh debates his mother Shobha about the power of devotion and disease, declaring his disbelief in divine healing when his own illness worsens daily. The play diagnoses how political actors in contemporary rural Mithila use personal illness and misfortune as instruments of social stigma and character destruction.

## 3.6 Mukti Yatra (मुक्ति यात्रा) — Journey of Liberation

Jha's most recent and most ambitious play (c. 2015-16, published by Navarambh Prakashan), Mukti Yatra breaks significant new dramatic ground.

The critical preface identifies its central concerns: the situation of martyred soldiers' families who face not only government neglect but active persecution by enemy agents; the grotesque of robotic surveillance technology (a 'robotic crow' appears as a mechanical dramatic device); women's liberation as an undertone (antarlaya) of the narrative; and the dangers of mutual suspicion in contemporary society. The play is described as suitable for both rural and urban stages — a deliberate attempt to bridge the village-stage and urban proscenium-stage formats that Jha's earlier plays inhabited.

The critical preface by Rinku Devi places the play explicitly within Maithili dramatic history, tracing the tradition from Charyyapada (Buddhist devotional songs), through Varna Ratnakar's evidence of rich Loka-Natya (folk theatre) in medieval Mithila, to Jyotirishwar's Dhurta Samagam, Vidyapati's dramatic works, and the modern tradition. It argues: 'Maithili dramatic history has its roots in drama. There was a time when Maithili dramatic performance (Maithili Natak ka Digdigia) resounded across all of India, especially in North India.' The play is presented as Jha's definitive claim on this inheritance.

## 4. Critical Appreciation through Indian Literary Theories

### 4.1 Rasa Theory (Bharata Muni's Natyashastra)

Bharata Muni's Natyashastra (c. 200 BCE–200 CE) is the foundational Indian text on dramatic theory. Its central contribution is the Rasa theory: the idea that drama communicates through eight primary aesthetic emotions (Rasas) — Shringara (love/beauty), Hasya (humour), Karuna (pathos), Raudra (fury), Vira (heroism), Bhayanaka (terror), Bibhatsa (disgust), and Adbhuta (wonder) — with the ninth, Shanta (peace), added later. Each Rasa is produced by the interplay of: Sthayi Bhava (enduring emotion), Vibhava (determinants/causes), Anubhava (consequent expressions), and Vyabhichari Bhava (transitory emotions).

Bharata writes in the Natyashastra (Chapter 6): 'Rasa is produced from the combination of Vibhava, Anubhava, and Vyabhichari Bhava. Just as the taste (rasa) of food is produced from various ingredients, similarly the Rasa of dramatic composition is produced from the combination of Vibhava etc.' The Natyashastra further defines the social function of drama: it exists to give 'relief to those afflicted by sorrow, fatigue, or grief, and to bring joy, entertainment,

and delight to all people.' Drama is explicitly conceived as a democratic, inclusive public art: 'There is no wisdom, no learning, no yoga, no action which is not found in drama' (Natyashastra 1.116).

## 4.2 The Eight Rasas in Jha's Drama

The dominant Rasa across Jha's entire dramatic corpus is Karuna (pathos) — the rasa of sorrow, compassion, and the recognition of suffering. Takak Mol, Dhadhait, and Badlait Samaj are primarily Karuna dramas: the suffering of dowry victims, the death of brides, the wasting of young men's lives through disease and political persecution, all evoke this fundamental emotion. The Vibhava (determinant cause) of Karuna in Takak Mol is the systematic impoverishment of Garib Jha's family by the dowry economy; the Anubhava (expression) is Prabha's devotional song and tears; the Vyabhichari Bhava (transitory emotions) include anxiety, hope, despondency, and resolution.

Vira Rasa (heroism) is the dominant rasa of Hathat Parivartan and Mukti Yatra. The Pratap family's military heritage, the soldier-son Gopal's sacrifice at the border, the dramatic confrontation between patriotic duty and domestic weakness — all these generate the Vira aesthetic. The Natyashastra identifies Vira as 'the source from which all other rasas spring' (Chapter 6) — a claim particularly resonant in Jha's patriotic dramas where heroic sacrifice provides the moral measure against which all domestic weakness is evaluated.

Hasya (comedy) operates as secondary rasa in Kalah and Hathat Parivartan, providing comic relief through characters like Lutan Kaka (the mediating elder in Kalah), Sajendra's drunken calculations in Hathat Parivartan ('if I hadn't drunk, I'd have three lakh sixty-five thousand rupees in the bank by now'), and the marriage-broker's dialogue in Takak Mol. This strategic deployment of Hasya as Vyabhichari Bhava (transitory accompanying emotion) alongside the dominant Karuna is precisely the technique Bharata describes for sustained dramatic effect.

Raudra Rasa (fury) punctuates climactic scenes: Akash's physical violence against Aarti in Kalah, the bride-burning in Dhadhait, the political protagonist's character-assassination attempts in Badlait Samaj. Bibhatsa (disgust and revulsion) is evoked through these same scenes, particularly the burning bride motif — what Bharata identifies as the rasa of repulsion that produces moral awakening in the audience.

## 4.3 Abhinaya: The Four Modes of Expression

The Natyashastra identifies four modes of dramatic expression (Abhinaya): Angika (bodily/gestural), Vachika (verbal), Aharya (costume/make-up/scenery), and Sattvika (emotional/psychic). Jha's drama, designed for both village and urban stages, demonstrates sophisticated engagement with all four modes.

Vachika Abhinaya (verbal expression) is Jha's strongest mode: his dialogue is in authentic Maithili village idiom, class-differentiated (the poor Brahmin speaks differently from the politician; the soldier's family speaks differently from the village broker), and emotionally calibrated to the rasa economy of each scene. The dramatic announcement (Ghoshana) that opens Hathat Parivartan — in formal, elevated Maithili — establishes the patriotic emotional register before a word of dialogue is spoken.

Aharya Abhinaya (visual/scenic presentation) in Jha's plays is consistently minimal: the stage directions specify domestic settings (a room with a radio and a bed in Kalah; a prosperous haveli in Hathat Parivartan; a poor man's house with a deity's photograph in Takak Mol) that can be easily reproduced on village stages. This economy of staging is both a material necessity for village-theatre production and a dramaturgical principle: the plays' power derives from human interaction, not spectacular visual effect.

## 4.4 Vritti (Dramatic Style)

The Natyashastra classifies drama into four Vrittis (dramatic styles): Bharati (verbal/intellectual), Sattvati (heroic/noble), Kaisiki (gentle/erotic), and Arabhati (violent/impetuous). Jha's plays deploy different Vrittis in different contexts. Hathat Parivartan and Mukti Yatra predominantly employ Sattvati Vritti: the noble-heroic register appropriate to representations of military sacrifice and patriotic duty. Kalah and Takak Mol predominantly use Bharati Vritti: the conversational-intellectual register in which social argument is conducted through dialogue. Dhadhait uses Arabhati Vritti in its violent climax: the impetuous, forceful register of the bride-burning scene. Kaisiki Vritti appears in the romantic sub-plots of Takak Mol and the tender scenes between Shikha and Sameer in Dhadhait.

## 4.5 Natyashastra's Social Function (Lokasangraha)

The Natyashastra explicitly positions drama as a form of social instruction (Lokasangraha — 'holding together the world/society'). Bharata writes: 'I shall

now speak of the objectives of drama (Natyaprayojana): the instruction of all people, the giving of advice to those without teachers, the amusement of people worn out by labour, and the demonstration of what is dharma and adharma.' This social-didactic function is precisely how Jha conceives his own practice. His preface to Takak Mol states that he writes 'to advise the young men and women of the new generation to come forward openly' against the dowry system. His note in Dhadhait defines drama as 'the most successful and simple literary form for bringing public consciousness.'

Jha's theatrical practice embodies what Bharata calls Nata-dharma (the law of the actor/dramatist): the obligation to speak to the fullness of social reality, not to entertain alone. This is why his plays consistently end with positive exemplars: a young man who refuses dowry demands (Takak Mol), a patriotic son whose sacrifice redeems a family's honour (Hathat Parivartan), honest youth who resist political manipulation (Badlait Samaj). These resolutions are not naive optimism but Lokasangraha — the dramatist's obligation to 'hold society together' by demonstrating that alternatives to oppression are possible.

## 4.6 Dhvani Theory (Anandavardhana)

Anandavardhana's Dhvanyaloka (9th century CE) — the theory of suggestion (dhvani) as the soul of poetry — is particularly applicable to Jha's dramatic language. The title 'Takak Mol' (The Price of Money) is itself a powerful dhvani: literally the price/value of money, it suggests that money has become the measure of everything — of a bride's worth, of a child's education, of family honour, of human relationships. This dhvani resonates throughout the play without any character explicitly articulating it. Similarly, 'Dhadhait' (smouldering/burning) in the title 'Dhadhait Navki Kaniyank Lahas' operates on multiple registers: the physical burning of the bride, the smouldering injustice of the social system, the slow burning of family honour, and the burning indignation of the audience — all suggested by this single word.

In Hathat Parivartan (Sudden Change), the dhvani operates through the contrast between the haveli's noble history and the present degeneracy: the stones that 'seem to tell stories of sacrifice' stand in ironic dhvani-relation to Giridhar's alcoholic waste. This is what Anandavardhana calls Alamkara-dhvani — the resonance produced by an ironic disproportion between surface and depth, between what is shown and what is suggested.

### 4.7 Vakrokti (Kuntaka) and Auchitya (Kshemendra)

Kuntaka's theory of Vakrokti (oblique/creative deviation) illuminates Jha's dramatic irony. The character of Dalal (the marriage broker) in Takak Mol speaks in the most polite, deferential Maithili, offering his 'services' with elaborate courtesy — while his actual function is extortion and exploitation. This gap between his verbal style (indirect, obliging) and his social function (predatory) is a sustained Vakrokti: the creative deviation that produces the bitter comedy of the broker-merchant alliance in the dowry economy.

Kshemendra's Auchitya (contextual propriety) is particularly relevant to Jha's village-theatre aesthetics. Every element of his dramatic language — the Maithili dialect register, the domestic settings, the prayer-songs embedded in Takak Mol, the folk-idioms of village dispute in Kalah — achieves perfect Auchitya: contextual appropriateness to the social world, the characters, and the audience. This is the aesthetic principle that makes his plays performable by village troupes with minimal technical resources.

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## 5. Village Theatre and Folk Drama Theories

### 5.1 Mithila's Loka-Natya Tradition

The critical preface to Mukti Yatra traces Maithili dramatic history back to Charyyapada (the Buddhist devotional songs of the 8th-12th centuries CE) and the evidence of Loka-Natya (folk theatre) in Jyotirishwar Thakur's Varna Ratnakar (14th century CE). This is a profound genealogical claim: that Maithili theatre is not derivative of Sanskrit classical drama but has its own ancient folk-dramatic tradition, possibly preceding the Sanskrit literary tradition.

The essay explicitly argues: 'Considering Varna Ratnakar as the founding text of Maithili is a historical mistake we have made. The topics described in Varna Ratnakar prove that in the matter of Loka-Natya (folk performance including Nach etc.) we were rich from ancient times. The historical mistake of considering Varna Ratnakar as the first Maithili text should be reconsidered.' This is a significant intervention in Maithili literary historiography: it displaces the canonical origin story and asserts the priority of the folk-performance tradition.

The Nach (नाच) tradition — a distinctively Mithila form of musical theatre combining dialogue, song, dance, satire, and social commentary, performed at festivals and occasions by semi-professional village troupes — is the immediate performative ancestor of Jha's written plays. Nach performances historically addressed social issues (caste discrimination, women's oppression, economic exploitation), used Maithili folk music and idiom, and performed for village audiences in open-air settings. Jha's plays inherit this tradition's social commitment, folk-idiom, and performative accessibility while translating it into the more structured proscenium-stage or temporary-stage format.

## 5.2 Bertolt Brecht's Epic Theatre and Village Drama

Bertolt Brecht's theory of Epic Theatre (developed in the 1920s-40s) proposed a dramaturgy that disrupts illusionist identification, encourages critical distance, and produces a politically awakened spectator rather than an emotionally catharted one. Brecht's Verfremdungseffekt (V-Effekt or 'alienation effect') — techniques that prevent the audience from losing itself in the performance and instead make it think critically — has striking parallels with certain features of Maithili village theatre.

The Ghoshana (dramatic announcement) that opens Hathat Parivartan functions as a Brechtian narrator-frame: it introduces the dramatic situation in a detached, formal register before the action begins, preventing the audience's immediate emotional immersion and encouraging intellectual framing. Similarly, the songs embedded in Takak Mol — Prabha's devotional song about being born a poor man's daughter — function as what Brecht calls 'gestus songs': music that carries social commentary and interrupts the narrative flow.

However, the analogy is not complete. Brecht intended alienation to displace emotional identification entirely; Jha's village theatre relies on strong emotional identification (particularly the Karuna Rasa of the suffering bride, the poor father, the unemployed son) as its primary means of social communication. The village audience is not positioned as critical spectator but as empathetic participant. This reflects the difference between Brecht's avant-garde Western theatre and the socially embedded popular tradition of village theatre, which uses emotion rather than alienation as its path to social conscience.

## 5.3 Richard Schechner's Environmental Theatre

Richard Schechner's theory of Environmental Theatre (1968 onwards) holds that theatre is not confined to the proscenium stage but exists in any environment that the performers and audience co-create as a theatrical space. Schechner draws on the anthropological work of Victor Turner and Erving Goffman to argue that all performance is ritual, and all ritual is potentially theatre.

This framework is highly applicable to the originary performance context of Jha's plays: village festivals (Durga Puja, Janaki Navami), open courtyards, temporary stages constructed for specific occasions. The first performance of Dhadhait at a Durga Puja celebration on 12 October 2002, by a village troupe (Sri Prabhakar Abhinay Samiti, Gandhwari), in an outdoor or semi-outdoor ritual context, is precisely the Environmental Theatre situation Schechner describes. The audience is not passive spectator but ritual community participant; the performance space is the community's own gathering space; the play is embedded in a broader ritual-social event.

## 5.4 Augusto Boal's Theatre of the Oppressed

Augusto Boal's Theatre of the Oppressed (1974) — developed in Brazil for use with poor and marginalised communities — proposes drama as a form of 'rehearsal for revolution': a means by which oppressed people can explore, articulate, and begin to transform the social conditions that oppress them. Boal's techniques include Forum Theatre (where audience members become 'spect-actors' who intervene in the performance to try out different responses to oppression) and Image Theatre (where frozen body images express social relationships).

The social project of Jha's dramatic writing maps closely onto Boal's framework. The dowry victims, unemployed youth, and politically persecuted villagers who are Jha's dramatic subjects are precisely the 'oppressed' whose rehearsal for alternative responses to oppression Boal describes. Takak Mol functions as Forum Theatre: by dramatising the full logic of the dowry economy — the broker's manipulation, the father's despair, the daughter's prayer, the young man's potential resistance — it invites the village audience to imaginatively rehearse the refusal of this logic. The play's resolution — the young man who refuses dowry demands — is exactly the 'spect-actor intervention' Boal identifies as the goal of Forum Theatre.

# 6. Western Literary and Critical Theories

## 6.1 Aristotelian Dramaturgy

Aristotle's Poetics (c. 335 BCE) defines drama through its six constituent elements: Mythos (plot), Ethos (character), Dianoia (thought/theme), Lexis (language/diction), Melos (song/music), and Opsis (spectacle). It privileges Mythos as the 'soul of tragedy': the structured sequence of actions that produces recognition (Anagnorisis) and reversal (Peripeteia), culminating in Catharsis — the purgation of fear and pity in the audience.

Jha's plays conform to the Aristotelian definition in several respects. Each play has a clear Mythos: Takak Mol's plot moves through exposition (Garib's poverty and desperation), rising action (the broker's manipulations, the social pressure), recognition (the young man's insight into the system), and resolution (his refusal). Dhadhait's Mythos is structured around the fatal peripeteia of the bride's death. Hathat Parivartan's Mythos moves towards the anagnorisis of Giridhar's recognition of his own degradation against his family's heroic legacy.

However, Aristotle's insistence on single unified plot (the 'unity of action') is less applicable to Jha's multi-strand village dramas, which characteristically weave several social issues simultaneously. Kalah, for instance, develops parallel strands of mother-in-law/daughter-in-law conflict, unemployment, and domestic violence simultaneously — a multiple-strand structure more characteristic of Indian village drama than Aristotelian unity.

## 6.2 Feminist Theory and the Drama of Women's Oppression

Feminist dramatic theory (Sue-Ellen Case, Jill Dolan, Elin Diamond) examines how theatre represents, constructs, and potentially challenges gender oppression. The female body on stage — who controls it, how it is displayed, what social meanings are attached to it — is a central concern. Jha's drama is saturated with the politics of women's bodies: Prabha's body is a financial liability in the dowry economy (Takak Mol); the new bride's body is literally burned when her dowry proves insufficient (Dhadhait); Aarti's body is the target of domestic violence (Kalah); female characters in Hathat Parivartan and Badlait Samaj are subject to various forms of social control and character assassination.

Jha's treatment of these themes is not feminist in the theoretical sense — he does not question the patriarchal structures themselves but protests their extreme, brutal manifestations. His heroines are sympathetic sufferers rather

than agents of structural transformation. This is consistent with the populist-reformist tradition of village social drama, which aims to modify behaviour within existing structures rather than to challenge the structures themselves. However, the very act of staging female suffering — of making visible what is normally confined to domestic space — performs a feminist function in the context of village performance culture.

## 6.3 Postcolonial Theory and Social Drama

Frantz Fanon's analysis of colonial violence and its internalisation (The Wretched of the Earth, 1961) provides a framework for reading the political drama in Badlait Samaj. The play's central conflict — between honest young men (Avdhesh, Deepak, Vijendra) and a corrupt politician (Netaji) who uses traditional power structures to destroy the reputation of those who threaten his authority — maps precisely onto Fanon's analysis of how postcolonial elites reproduce colonial structures of violence and domination at the village level.

Homi Bhabha's concept of 'mimicry' — the colonised subject's imperfect imitation of the coloniser — appears in the characterisation of Giridhar in Hathat Parivartan: his alcohol consumption, his English-educated contempt for tradition ('ई इङ्ग्लिशक रामायण' — 'This is the Ramayana in English' — he says mockingly), and his disconnection from his family's heroic identity represent a form of cultural mimicry that has dissolved without producing genuine modernity. The 'sudden change' of the title is the hoped-for reversal of this mimicry-driven alienation.

## 6.4 Marxist/Materialist Dramaturgy

Raymond Williams's cultural materialism and the Marxist dramatic tradition of Raymond Williams, Walter Benjamin, and Theodor Adorno provide tools for reading the economic determinism that underlies all of Jha's social dramas. The plays consistently locate social dysfunction in economic conditions: the dowry system is not a cultural aberration but an economic structure that systematically transfers wealth from poor families to prosperous ones. Unemployment is not an individual failure but a structural condition of rural Bihar's under-developed economy. Domestic violence is not a psychological pathology but a consequence of economic powerlessness expressing itself through gender domination.

This materialist analysis of social evil — tracing individual suffering to structural economic conditions — is precisely the Marxist theatrical tradition

that Walter Benjamin admired in Brecht: the capacity to show the social origin of human suffering rather than attributing it to individual psychology or fate.

### 6.5 Psychoanalytic Theory

Freudian and Lacanian psychoanalysis, applied to theatre (by critics such as Julia Kristeva and Jane Gallop), offers insights into the unconscious dynamics of Jha's drama. The character of Akash in Kalah — violent towards his wife yet dependent on his family, unable to earn yet unable to accept his economic failure — exhibits what Freud called 'narcissistic injury': the wound to male self-image that occurs when economic failure makes the patriarchal provider-role impossible. His violence against Aarti is a displacement of this narcissistic injury onto the nearest available body.

The figure of Giridhar in Hathat Parivartan — the alcoholic son who unconsciously undermines the military heroism of his father and brother — exhibits what Lacan calls the 'lack' at the centre of identity: the impossibility of living up to the symbolic mandate of the Father (the Brigadier, the heroic soldier-ancestor). Giridhar's alcohol is not simply vice but a symptom of this Lacanian impossibility — the unconscious refusal of an identity he cannot inhabit.

## 7. The Videha Parallel History Framework

Gajendra Thakur's Videha Maithili eJournal (www.videha.co.in, ISSN 2229-547X) has established what its editorial tradition calls a 'Parallel History' (Samanantar Itihas) of Maithili drama and literature — an alternative critical framework that contests the dominant upper-caste, institutionally-sanctioned literary history.

The Videha essay on Maithili theatre and drama (archived at maithili-samalochna.blogspot.com) explicitly names Anand Kumar Jha in its survey of contemporary Maithili playwrights, alongside Mahendra Malangiya, Uday Narayan Singh 'Nachiketa', Bhasakarananda Jha, Ashutosh Kumar Mishra, Manoj Manuj, Sanjiv Mishra, Swati Singh, and others. This placement is significant: it locates Jha within the Videha Parallel History project's canon of socially committed, non-institutionally dominant writers.

The Videha Parallel History framework is particularly relevant to understanding Jha's dramatic achievement for several reasons: First, Jha writes

from a village location (Menhath, Jhanjharpur) rather than the metropolitan centres (Patna, Delhi, Kolkata) that dominate mainstream Maithili literary culture. Second, his plays circulate primarily through village performance networks — amateur theatre groups, festival stages, community events — rather than through academic institutions or literary establishments. Third, his subject matter — dowry, domestic violence, unemployment, political corruption, military sacrifice in rural families — addresses precisely the social constituencies that dominant Maithili literary culture has historically underrepresented.

The Videha Archive's preservation of his plays in digital form represents the Parallel History framework's key practical function: archiving and democratising access to literary works that would otherwise remain confined to small print runs and limited local distribution. The availability of Jha's plays on the Videha Archive ensures that his work is accessible to scholars, directors, and readers across the global Maithili-speaking diaspora.

The preface to Mukti Yatra's literary-historical argument — recentring Charyyapada and Loka-Natya as the true origin of Maithili drama — is itself a Parallel History intervention: it contests the canonisation of Varna Ratnakar as the founding Maithili text and asserts the folk-performance tradition as the more ancient and more democratically rooted origin of Maithili literary expression.

## 8. Navya Nyaya Epistemology Applied to Drama

Navya Nyaya (New Logic), the school of Indian epistemology that originated in Mithila with Gaṅgeśa Upadhyaya's Tattvacintamani (c. 13th century CE) and was elaborated by successive generations of Maithili logicians, offers a distinctive epistemological framework for analysing dramatic cognition. Applying Navya Nyaya to Jha's drama is not merely a technical exercise but an act of cultural hermeneutics: reading works produced within the Mithila cultural tradition through the epistemological tools that same tradition produced.

## 8.1 Pramana in Theatrical Cognition

The Naiyayika tradition identifies four Pramanas (sources of valid knowledge): Pratyaksha (direct perception), Anumana (inference), Upamana (comparison/analogy), and Shabda (verbal testimony). Theatre, as a form of cognitive experience, engages all four Pramanas simultaneously and in distinctive configurations.

In the theatrical situation, Pratyaksha operates differently from everyday perception: the audience perceives real actors on a real stage, but cognitively processes them as fictional characters in a fictional situation. This is what the Natyashastra calls the distinctive theatrical mode of knowledge — a conditioned Pratyaksha in which real and fictional are held simultaneously in consciousness. In Jha's village drama, the proximity of actor and audience (village-stage performance), the use of known actors from within the community, and the social recognisability of the dramatic situations intensify this dual Pratyaksha: the audience simultaneously perceives both the actor (whom they know) and the character (whose social type they recognise).

Anumana (inferential knowledge) is activated when the audience infers social causes from dramatic effects. When Avdhesh in Badlait Samaj grows progressively sicker despite his wife's care and prayers, the Anumana is: this illness is not merely physical but social — produced by the stress of poverty, the absence of adequate healthcare, and the persecution of political enemies. The audience's inferential process moves from the particular dramatic event to the general social condition, which is the primary educational function of social drama.

## 8.2 Vyapti and the Logic of Social Drama

Gaṅgeśa's central contribution to Navya Nyaya is the precise analysis of Vyapti — the invariable concomitance (universal rule) that makes inferential reasoning valid. 'Where there is smoke, there is fire' is valid because of the Vyapti: smoke is invariably concomitant with fire. Navya Naiyayikas developed an extraordinarily precise technical vocabulary for establishing and testing Vyaptis, distinguishing genuine from merely apparent concomitances.

Jha's social dramas operate by constructing dramatic evidence that tests and ultimately refutes the dominant social Vyaptis of Mithila's patriarchal-feudal world. The apparent Vyapti 'where there is a daughter, there is a debt' (the dowry economy's cultural logic) is the false universal that Takak Mol subjects to dramatic testing. Through the particular story of Garib Jha's family — five

daughters, twelve katthas of land, no savings — the play accumulates dramatic evidence (Vyabhichari counter-instances) against this Vyapti: Prabha's devotion, intelligence, and college education are presented as positive qualities that ought to make her a desirable bride independent of dowry. The play's resolution — the young man who refuses dowry — produces what Navya Nyaya calls Badhakapramana: defeating evidence that nullifies the false Vyapti.

In Navya Nyaya terms, Dhadhait Navki Kaniyank Lahas constructs the most powerful Badhakapramana of all: the bride's burned body is the ultimate counter-instance that defeats the Vyapti 'the dowry system is natural/inevitable.' The dramatic spectacle of this extreme consequence — shown not sanitised but in its full horror — is the epistemically effective defeat of the social logic that produces it.

## 8.3 Tarka (Counter-argument) in the Plays

Navya Nyaya's sophisticated analysis of Tarka (hypothetical reasoning/counter-argument) is visible in the dramatic debates that structure Jha's plays. In Kalah, the extended dialogue between Akash and his father Sureshwar about money, employment, and family obligation is a sustained Tarka structure: each character advances inferential claims (Anumana) based on different Vyaptis about the responsibilities of sons and daughters-in-law, and the dialogue moves through a sequence of Tarka counter-arguments without reaching a stable resolution — because the underlying economic condition (unemployment) that produces the conflict remains unresolved.

In Hathat Parivartan, the Tarka debate is between the value systems of military sacrifice and urban hedonism: Sajendra's argument ('if I hadn't drunk I'd be a lakh-pati') is a Tarka that appropriates the logic of economic rationality in defence of alcohol, only to be defeated by the superior Tarka of family honour and patriotic duty. This is precisely the Navya Nyaya dialectic of Vada (sincere debate) in which the debaters are genuinely engaged in truth-seeking, not merely scoring points.

## 8.4 Shabda Pramana and Theatrical Authority

In Navya Nyaya, Shabda Pramana (verbal testimony) is valid when it derives from an Apta — a reliable, authoritative witness with direct knowledge. The question of who counts as Apta in Maithili dramatic culture is a cultural-political question: whose testimony about social reality is authorised to be heard on the public stage?

Jha's dramatic project involves a systematic expansion of Apta-hood: the poor father (Garib Jha in Takak Mol), the suffering daughter-in-law (Aarti in Kalah), the burning bride (in Dhadhait), the sick young man (Avdhesh in Badlait Samaj) — all are constituted as reliable witnesses to social reality. Their testimony — delivered in authentic Maithili village idiom, from within the full specificity of their social situation — is the Shabda Pramana that the drama validates against the dominant cultural testimony of those who benefit from the dowry system, domestic violence, and political corruption. This is the epistemological democracy of village theatre: the stage as a space where the Apta-hood of the subaltern is publicly constituted.

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# 9. Individual Play Analyses

## 9.1 Takak Mol: Dramaturgy of the Dowry Economy

Takak Mol's opening scene — Prabha worshipping before a deity's photograph, singing a song of lament about being born poor — establishes the play's central dramatic and social frame: the interplay between religious resignation and social protest. The deity photograph, the prayer, and the song are simultaneously an Aharya setting element (visual stage image), a Sattvika Abhinaya (spiritual-emotional expression), and a dhvani: the gap between Prabha's devotion and the social indifference to her situation suggests the inadequacy of religious consolation for structural social injustice.

The character of Garib Jha — whose name literally means 'poor Jha' — is a Brechtian social type as much as an individualised character: he embodies the structural position of the poor upper-caste Brahmin father in the dowry economy, whose social status (Brahmin) prevents him from manual labour ('born a Brahmin, not able to plough like a low caste') while his poverty makes the dowry demands of his daughters' marriages financially catastrophic. This double bind — social status that prohibits economic alternatives, combined with economic incapacity to fulfil the social obligations that status requires — is the structural trap that Takak Mol exposes with social-realist precision.

The broker-character (Dalal) and his sidekick (Chela) function as comic-satirical figures in the tradition of Hasya Rasa characters: their elaborate courtesy masks naked financial exploitation, and their dialogue with Garib Jha provides the play's most biting social satire ('in two to four days I'll find a match — though I should mention one more thing I forgot to say...' — perpetually

raising the dowry demand). This satirical register is both an entertainment device and an epistemological tool: by exposing the broker's manipulation with comic clarity, the play demystifies the marriage-market's logic for the village audience.

## 9.2 Kalah: The Architecture of Domestic Violence

Kalah's dramatic architecture is a study in escalation: from small domestic irritations (Sumitra's jealousy of her daughter-in-law's radio, her complaint about 'that troublemaker who came to our house to set it on fire') through verbal attack to physical violence. The play maps the psychology of joint-family conflict with considerable nuance: Sumitra's aggression is not simply spite but the displacement of her own frustrated maternal ambition onto the daughter-in-law who has 'stolen' her son; Akash's violence is not simply cruelty but the expression of his economic impotence in the only domain where he retains power (domestic authority over his wife); Sureshwar's weakness is not simply cowardice but the exhaustion of a man who has worked his whole life to maintain a family structure now held together only by force.

The character Lutan Kaka — the intervening elder — represents the traditional mediation function of the village community, whose authority over domestic violence has eroded in the conditions of semi-urban alienation (the 'Akash' family lives in what the play implies is a town or semi-urban setting, not a village). His inability to prevent Akash's violence despite his intervention is the play's most sobering social diagnosis: the traditional communal mechanisms of conflict resolution are no longer adequate to contain the violence produced by economic dispossession.

## 9.3 Hathat Parivartan: Patriotism and Domestic Degeneration

Hathat Parivartan's dramaturgical strategy is the sustained ironic contrast between the military heroism of the Pratap family tradition (encoded in the haveli's 'stones that speak of sacrifice') and the domestic comedy-tragedy of the drunkard son Giridhar. This ironic structure — noble past, degraded present — is a classic device of Indian traditional theatre (comparing present degeneration with past glory) adapted to the contemporary social reality of urban-educated youth unable to inhabit the values of their families.

The play's most dramatically powerful scene — the grandson Rohan's questions to his soldier-father Gopal ('Grandpa says you are a Commander, what do you do as Commander, Papa?') — is a moment of pure Anagnorisis in the Aristotelian sense: the recognition of what heroism truly is, articulated

through a child's innocent curiosity, against the background of Giridhar's comic-pathetic degradation. This structural juxtaposition achieves both Karuna (pity for the family's predicament) and Vira (admiration for military sacrifice) simultaneously — a sophisticated double-Rasa effect.

### 9.4 Mukti Yatra: Theatre of National Security and Women's Liberation

Mukti Yatra represents a significant formal and thematic advance on Jha's earlier plays. The 'robotic crow' — a mechanical surveillance device used by enemy agents — is the most avant-garde dramatic device in his entire corpus: it brings the technology of modern warfare and espionage into the village-drama space, forcing a collision between rural domestic experience and geopolitical reality. This device has precedents in the Natyashastra's tradition of Nanavakya (wondrous/unusual dramatic elements that produce Adbhuta Rasa), but also anticipates contemporary performance art's engagement with drone technology and digital surveillance.

The play's complex plot — soldier's family under persecution, women's liberation as undertone, robotic surveillance, the identification of enemies within — is deliberately designed to work on both village and urban stages. This formal ambition reflects Jha's mature understanding that the village-stage/urban-stage binary is itself a social construction that his dramatic practice can help dissolve.

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## 10. Thematic Synthesis

#### *a. The Structural Violence of the Dowry Economy*

Across Takak Mol and Dhadhait Navki Kaniyank Lahas — and implicitly present in Kalah and Badlait Samaj — the dowry economy appears not as individual greed or cultural backwardness but as a structural feature of the Maithili-Brahmin social economy: a system that systematically extracts surplus value from poor families, disciplines women's bodies and lives, and produces the material conditions for domestic violence and bride-murder. Jha's persistent return to this theme across multiple plays constitutes a sustained, multi-angled dramatic indictment of this system.

### *b. Unemployment and the Crisis of Masculinity*

From Akash in Kalah to Giridhar in Hathat Parivartan to the young men of Badlait Samaj, Jha's drama consistently diagnoses the crisis of young educated Maithili men who cannot find employment appropriate to their education and social status. This crisis of masculinity — the inability to fulfil the provider-role that patriarchal social structure defines as masculine identity — is shown to produce domestic violence (Kalah), hedonistic escapism (Hathat Parivartan), and susceptibility to political manipulation (Badlait Samaj). Jha's is the drama of a generation educated beyond the economic opportunities available to it.

### *c. Patriotism, Sacrifice, and National Identity*

Hathat Parivartan and Mukti Yatra constitute a distinctive strand of patriotic drama within Jha's corpus. Both plays invoke the military sacrifice of families from the rural Maithili-speaking regions — a sacrifice that is largely invisible in dominant national discourse, which tends to locate military heroism in Rajput and Punjabi martial cultures rather than Bihari Brahmin or other Maithili families. Jha's patriotic drama is thus also an act of cultural-political visibility: asserting the presence of Mithila's sons and daughters within the national security narrative.

### *d. The Corruption of Village Democracy*

Badlait Samaj and, to some extent, Takak Mol, diagnose the corruption of village democratic life by political actors (Netaji, the politician) who use traditional social authority, economic dependency, and cultural prestige to maintain dominance against the aspirations of honest young people. This is Jha's contribution to a genre of Indian social drama concerned with the distortion of Panchayati Raj (local self-governance) by organised political power.

### *e. The Village Stage as Social Institution*

Across all six plays, Jha's consistent orientation toward village-stage performance — the amateur troupe, the festival context, the non-elite audience — constitutes his most fundamental social position: drama is a democratic public institution, not an elite entertainment. This is the practical embodiment of Bharata's Natyashastra principle that drama exists for 'all people' — not for scholars, aristocrats, or urban elites but for the full range of social classes and conditions that constitute the dramatic audience.

## 11. Conclusion and Critical Assessment

Anand Kumar Jha's six plays, taken together, constitute one of the most sustained and socially grounded bodies of dramatic writing in contemporary Maithili literature. From the debut anti-dowry play Takak Mol (2000) through the patriotic-military drama of Hathat Parivartan (Sahitya Akademi Youth Prize winner) to the ambitious multi-stranded Mukti Yatra (c. 2015-16), his dramatic career traces an arc from focused social protest to more complex engagement with questions of national identity, technological modernity, and women's liberation.

His greatest dramaturgical strength is the capacity for social-structural analysis delivered through emotionally compelling individual drama: the particular suffering of Garib Jha's family encodes the structural violence of the dowry economy; the particular degradation of Giridhar in the Pratap haveli encodes the structural crisis of educated but unemployed young Maithili men; the particular persecution of Avdhesh in Badlait Samaj encodes the structural corruption of village political life. This movement from particular to structural — from the individual dramatic situation to the social condition it typifies — is simultaneously what Bharata calls Rasa-production (the universalisation of emotion) and what Marxist dramaturgy calls ideological demystification.

His limitations, if any, lie in the relative predictability of his dramatic resolutions: plays that diagnose social pathologies with sharp realism tend to resolve them through exemplary individual virtue (the young man who refuses dowry, the patriotic son who reclaims family honour, the honest young man who resists political manipulation). These resolutions, while satisfying in terms of Lokasangraha (social instruction) and Vira Rasa (heroic inspiration), do not fully explore the structural conditions that make such individual virtue necessary or the reasons why it remains the exception rather than the rule. This is less a dramatic failure than a strategic choice appropriate to the village-stage context and its social function.

Through the multiple frameworks applied in this study — Bharata's Natyashastra and village theatre theory, Western dramaturgy from Aristotle to Brecht to Boal, feminist and Marxist dramatic criticism, the Videha Parallel History framework, and Navya Nyaya epistemology — a coherent and distinctive dramatic identity emerges: Anand Kumar Jha is a writer of the Mithila village stage in the deepest sense — not merely a writer for the village audience but a writer from within the village's social logic, its epistemological horizon, and its performance traditions. His drama is the most direct

contemporary descendant of the Mithila Nach tradition's social commitment: art as public conscience, theatre as the community's rehearsal for a more just society.

In the Natyashastra's terms, he fulfils Bharata's mandate: 'Drama gives instruction, pleasure, and advice to those without teachers; it corrects the conduct of those who are ignorant, and is a delight to those who are wise.' In the Navya Nyaya terms of Gaṅgeśa's epistemological tradition: his plays are Aptavakya — the valid testimony of a reliable witness — concerning the social reality of Mithila's rural communities in the late twentieth and early twenty-first centuries.

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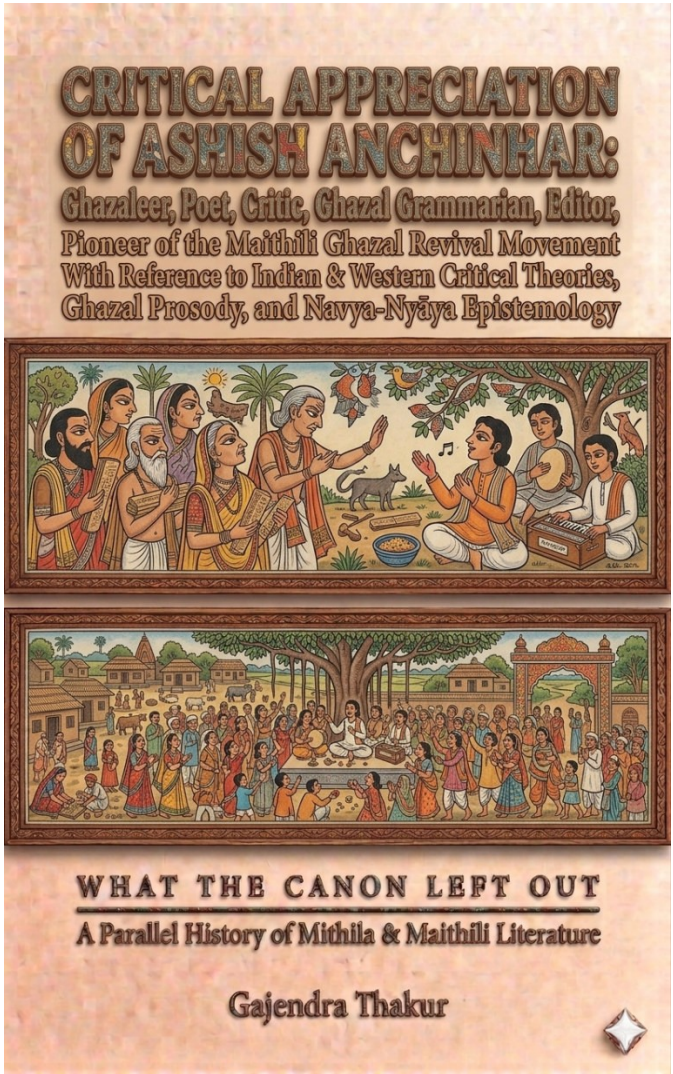
**LESSON 012 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**




## CRITICAL APPRECIATION OF

# ASHISH ANCHINHAR

*Ghazaleer, Poet, Critic, Ghazal Grammarian, Editor*

*Pioneer of the Maithili Ghazal Revival Movement*

With Reference to Indian & Western Critical Theories,
Ghazal Prosody, and Navya-Nyāya Epistemology

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# FOREWORD

This critical appreciation of Ashish Anchinhar (आशीष अनचिन्हार), born Ashish Kumar Mishra on 4 December 1985 in Bhatra Ghat, Bisfi, Madhubani (Mithila) Bihar, represents a sustained attempt to situate his contribution to Maithili literature within the interlocking frameworks of classical Arabic-Persian ghazal poetics, modern Indian literary criticism, Western critical theory, and the epistemological rigour associated with the Navya-Nyāya tradition of Mithila  particularly as codified by Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya in the Tattvacintāmaṇi. Anchinhar's work is inseparable from the Videha Parallel Literature Movement spearheaded by Gajendra Thakur through the Videha eJournal (ISSN 2229-547X, www.videha.co.in), the first Maithili fortnightly eJournal, which has served since 2000 as the primary institutional vehicle for democratising Maithili literary production against the hegemony of the Sahitya Akademi canon.

The books consulted for this study include Anchinhar's own published volumes available through the Videha archive: Anchinhar Aakhar (2011, Shruti Publication, Delhi), Maithili Ghazalak Vyakaran O Itihas, Sandarbh Sahit, Maithili Ghazal: Aagaman O Prasthan Bandh (co-edited with Gajendra Thakur), Maithilīk Pratinidhi Ghazal 1905-2022 (co-edited with Gajendra Thakur), Swatantracheta Arvind Thakur (edited), and the major critical appreciation volumes Preeti Karan Setu Banhal (edited) and Setusham: Vibrant Maithili (edited). These primary sources are read alongside the Videha archive and the broader tradition of Maithili, Urdu, Persian, Arabic, and comparative literary scholarship.

The study is organised into seven major sections: (I) biographical and intellectual context; (II) the ghazal form and Anchinhar's formal innovations; (III) thematic and ideological dimensions of his poetry; (IV) his contribution as a critic and theorist; (V) reading Anchinhar through Indian critical traditions; (VI) Western critical frameworks applied to his work; and (VII) Navya-Nyāya epistemology as a meta-critical lens for his poetics of evidence, inference, and literary sabda-śakti.

# I. BIOGRAPHICAL AND INTELLECTUAL CONTEXT

*Around 2008, a proposal was made to Ashish Anachinhar to become the Sub-Editor of Videha. However, he did not accept the position; instead, he became a collaborator of Videha anonymously and continues to be a collaborator to this day. From time to time, Ashish Anachinhar keeps providing many creative ideas for Videha, which reach the readers through the medium of the publication.*

*People from the "mainstream" and the Sahitya Akademi harbor a sense of resentment toward Ashish Anachinhar's work. The reason is that his work publicly exposes the incompetence of both the mainstream and the Akademi. Consequently, apart from the Samanantar Dhara (Parallel Stream), he remains excluded from the lists of any other awards.*

## 1.1 Life and Formation

Ashish Anchinhar was born on 4 December 1985 in Bhatra Ghat, Bisfi, Madhubani district of Bihar - the heartland of Mithila. His father Shri Krishna Chandra Mishra and mother Srimati Gambhira Mishra nurtured him in a region that has been, since at least the era of Pre-Jyotirishwar Vidyapati [different from

Vidyapati (1350-1435)], the crucible of Maithili literary sensibility. His pen name Anchinhar (अनचिन्हार, meaning 'unrecognised' or 'unfamiliar' one who is not yet known) carries with it both a manifesto and a challenge: to give voice to that which has been passed over, silenced, or misrecognised by the hegemonic apparatus of Sahitya Akademi-sanctioned literature.

He began writing Maithili ghazal and sher-o-shairi on the internet platform Anchinhar Aakhar (http://anchinharakharkolkata.blogspot.com/) from around 2000, making him one of the earliest consistent practitioners of the ghazal form in Maithili in the digital era. His formal debut as a published poet came with Anchinhar Aakhar (2011), a collection of Maithili ghazal, ruba'i, and kata - a volume distinguished by its strict adherence to Arabic-Persian bahr (metre) and its programmatic refusal to permit formally defective compositions to pass as ghazal.

Anchinhar received the Videha Bhasha Samman (the Videha equivalent of the Sahitya Akademi Award, the so-called 'Samaantar Sahitya Akademi Samman') for the year 2014 for Anchinhar Aakhar, awarded by Pankalal Mandal. This recognition, conferred by the Videha Parallel Literature Movement, is itself a political and aesthetic statement: the Videha movement deliberately constitutes an alternative canon-building institution, rewarding work that the Sahitya Akademi ignores or marginalises.

Through Videha, Anchinhar established himself as a collaborator of Gajendra Thakur in multiple co-edited volumes. His editorial work on Swatantracheta Arvind Thakur (2020, Shashi Prakashan, Kalikapur, Supaul) a revised edition of the Videha special issue on the poet Arvind Thakur demonstrates his engagement with the broader Mithila subaltern literary project.

## 1.2 The Videha Ecosystem and the Parallel Literature Movement

To understand Anchinhar's significance, one must understand Videha. Founded by Gajendra Thakur through the blog Bhalsarik Gachh (2000) — which constitutes the oldest surviving Maithili presence on the internet — and later institutionalised as Videha (since 1 January 2008), the eJournal publishes fortnightly and has accumulated an archive of over 258 web captures from 2004 to 2016 alone (Wayback Machine data). Its motto — Mānuṣīmahi Saṃskṛtām (from the Atharvaveda: 'Glorifying the human feminine/cultural') — announces its counter-hegemonic, subaltern-inclusive, gender-sensitive orientation.

The Videha Parallel Literature Movement, of which Anchinhar is a central figure, operates on several simultaneous axes: (a) formal correctness —

insisting on proper prosodic standards against the laxity that has permitted formally defective compositions to circulate as ghazal; (b) linguistic purification — privileging authentic Maithili lexicon and morphology over Hindi-influenced hybridisation; (c) ideological intervention — amplifying Dalit, subaltern, feminist, and non-Brahminical voices; (d) digital preservation — creating a permanent, publicly accessible, freely downloadable archive of Maithili literature; and (e) institutional rivalry — the movement explicitly positions itself against the Sahitya Akademi's canon-gatekeeping function.

Anchinhar's own books, all available through the Videha archive (www.videha.co.in/pothi.htm), embody this programme at every level, from formal prosodic rigour to the politics of recognition.

## 1.3 Published Works: An Overview

The following are Anchinhar's principal published works:

(1) Anchinhar Aakhar (अनचिन्हार आखर) — Ghazal, Ruba'i and Kata. Shruti Publication, New Delhi, 2011. ISBN 978-93-80538-48-8. This is his debut collection and the work that won the Videha Bhasha Samman 2014.

(2) Maithili Ghazalak Vyakaran O Itihas (मैथिली गजलक व्याकरण ओ इतिहास) — The Grammar and History of Maithili Ghazal. A comprehensive technical and historical monograph in 25 chapters covering ghazal grammar from Arabic-Persian-Urdu sources adapted for Maithili phonology, metre (bahr), rhyme (qafiya), refrain (radif), and a full history of the Maithili ghazal tradition from 1905 to the present.

(3) Sandarbh Sahit (संदर्भ सहित) — A collection of Anchinhar's critical essays, reviews, and analytical pieces on ghazal, ghazal prosody, and the question of what does or does not constitute a genuine ghazal in Maithili. This volume argues for strict formal standards against what Anchinhar calls 'kathit ghazal' (so-called ghazal) — compositions that bear the name but lack the formal substance.

(4) Maithili Ghazal: Aagaman O Prasthan Bandh (मैथिली गजल: आगमन ओ प्रस्थान बन्ध) — Co-edited with Gajendra Thakur. A critical anthology bringing together criticism, review, and analytical writing on ghazal by multiple critics including Om Prakash Jha, Amit Mishra, Jagdanand Jha 'Manu', Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil', and Muzna Ji. This is described as the first book in Maithili devoted exclusively to ghazal criticism.

(5) Maithilīk Pratinidhi Ghazal 1905-2022 (मैथिलीक प्रतिनिधि गजल) — Co-edited with Gajendra Thakur. A representative anthology of Maithili ghazal from 1905 (the year of the earliest documented Maithili ghazal by Pandit Jivan Jha) to 2022, divided by period and by formal category (Arabic bahr vs. simplified/folk metre).

(6) Swatantracheta Arvind Thakur (स्वतन्त्रचेता अरविन्द ठाकुर) — A monograph on the poet Arvind Thakur; edited work, 2020.

(7) Forthcoming/e-published: Jangha Jodi (जंघाजोड़ी), Kumari Ichchha (कुमारि इच्छा), Shabd-Arth-Shakti (शब्द-अर्थ-शक्ति — the first standalone Maithili ghazal criticism book), Maithili Ghazal Ready Reckoner.

He has edited Preeti Karan Setu Banhal: Redefining Maithili (2023, ISBN 978-93-340-0956-9) and Setusham: Vibrant Maithili (2026, ISBN 978-93-5717-358-2), the major critical appreciation volumes celebrating the literary contributions of Gajendra Thakur and Preeti Thakur.

# II. THE GHAZAL FORM: TRADITION, INNOVATION, AND ANCHINHAR'S CONTRIBUTION

## 2.1 The Classical Architecture of the Ghazal

The ghazal is among the most ancient and technically demanding of the lyric forms that migrated from Arabic through Persian and Urdu into the vernacular literatures of South Asia. In Arabic poetics, the form derives from the qasida tradition; the ghazal as an independent genre with its distinctive formal requirements crystallised during the Umayyad period (661-749 CE), with significant contributions from poets such as 'Umar ibn Abī Rabī'a (643-711 CE) and Jamīl Buthaynā (d. 701 CE). The Persian ghazal reached its classical pinnacle in the work of Hafiz Shirazi (1315-1390 CE), Sa'di, Rumi, and later Saba, Waqif, and Ghanī Kashmīrī. The form entered the Urdu literary tradition through Amīr Khusrau and was perfected by Mīr Taqī Mīr, Ghālib, and Momin.

The formal requirements of the classical ghazal, as articulated by Anchinhar in the Maithili Ghazalak Vyakaran O Itihas, are strictly defined. The ghazal must consist of a minimum of five and a maximum of seventeen she'r (verses/couplets); later practice has extended this range. Each she'r is formally complete and independent — this is the principle of beher-e-ghair-musalsal, the unconnected ghazal — though the musalsal (connected) variant also exists. The maqta' (closing couplet) traditionally contains the poet's takhallus (pen name). The matla' (opening couplet) establishes both the qafiya (rhyme) and the radif (refrain), with both hemistiches of the matla' carrying the qafiya and radif. All subsequent she'r carry the qafiya and radif only in the second hemistich. The bahr (metre) must be consistent throughout the ghazal; this is the most technically demanding requirement, as the bahr system is derived from Arabic prosody (arūḍ) which operates on a complex pattern of long (dīrgha) and short (laghu) syllables quite distinct from the syllabic-accentual patterns of Sanskrit vṛtta.

In Maithili, as Anchinhar demonstrates with painstaking analysis in the Vyakaran O Itihas, the application of Arabic-Persian bahr requires careful attention to Maithili-specific phonological features: the treatment of anusvara (nasalisation) and chandrabindu (nasal vowel modification), the status of

conjunct consonants (saṃyuktākṣara) in syllable weight, and the disambiguation of certain phonological categories (the distinction between e/ai and o/au) that have no exact parallel in either Sanskrit or Urdu phonology.

## 2.2 The Maithili Ghazal Tradition Before Anchinhar

Anchinhar, in his co-edited Maithilīk Pratinidhi Ghazal (1905-2022), provides the most comprehensive available history of the Maithili ghazal tradition. The earliest documented Maithili ghazal is attributed to Pandit Jivan Jha (active ca. 1905), whose ghazals show approximately 70-80% conformity to classical metre (bahr) — a remarkable achievement for the pioneering phase of a form whose technical requirements were being adapted from an entirely different language family. Anchinhar notes that even those earliest compositions that fall short technically nonetheless show awareness of the principle: 'jote bahan tatbahr se tat prakash jha ka ghazal se baher o bhaav noo si paripurn achhi.'

The period 1931-1970 saw contributions from Kavivara Sitaram Jha and Kashikant Dharm 'Madhup'. After 1970 through 2008, Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil', Yoganand Hira, and Vijanath Jha made significant contributions. The post-2008 phase, coinciding with the expansion of the Videha platform, saw the emergence of a systematic ghazal movement led by Anchinhar, Gajendra Thakur, Om Prakash Jha, Amit Mishra, Jagdanand Jha 'Manu', Pankaj Chaudhary 'Navalshri', and others.

Anchinhar's own historical survey identifies a persistent problem: from 1970 through approximately 2008, many Maithili literary figures published compositions they labelled 'ghazal' but which failed to meet the basic formal requirements of bahr, qafiya, or radif. His Sandarbh Sahit is partly a systematic critique of this tendency — a book he himself describes as the 'third book in Maithili devoted to ghazal criticism' (the first two being Gajendra Thakur's Maithili Samikshashstra and Anchinhar's own Shabd-Arth-Shakti).

## 2.3 Anchinhar's Formal Poetics

The defining characteristic of Anchinhar's own ghazals in Anchinhar Aakhar is strict formal correctness. In his brief introduction to the collection, he explains the word ghazal itself — derived from Arabic, with primary meanings of 'fine dust' (as when grain is threshed, the purest flour separates) and 'amorous conversation' — and reads these two meanings together as a formal-aesthetic programme: the ghazal is the art of separating the pure from the impure through a discipline of the word (ākhara), analogous to threshing, and it is simultaneously the articulation of desire in its most refined form — not merely

physical but spiritual, the discourse of the ātman as premi (beloved) with the paramātman as lover.

One of his characteristic ghazals from Anchinhar Aakhar illustrates his formal mastery:

> Ahã sanga prema karabāpara birata hama
> apatī Khetame marabāpara birata hama

The second misra' (hemistich) carries the radif 'par birat ham' and the qafiya follows the long-ā vowel rhyme pattern ('karbā', 'marbā'). The bahr is sustained throughout. This precision marks a deliberate contrast with the formally lax compositions he critiques as 'kathit ghazal' (so-called ghazal).

His use of Maithili-specific vocabulary and morphology — the verbal forms 'birat', 'marbā', 'karbā' — rather than Hinduised or Sanskritised alternatives, marks his adherence to what the Videha movement identifies as authentic Maithili linguistic identity. The choice of 'apaṭī khet' (the threshing field, or figuratively, the field of death/rites) connects the semantic field of the ghazal etymology (dust/threshing) to a Maithili cultural landscape.

## 2.4 The 'Anchinhar Formula' for Literary Evaluation

One of Anchinhar's most significant theoretical contributions is what he himself (with characteristic self-deprecating irony) calls the 'Anchinhar Formula' — a three-part evaluative criterion for judging any literary composition. The formula, articulated in the ghazal criticism preface to Maithili Ghazal: Aagaman O Prasthan Bandh, proposes three axes of evaluation:

First, Shakti-Kadraт (strength/power of relevance): Does the composition engage with power? If it addresses a contemporary figure or institution, how much 'distance' (rī, from Arabic) is there between the writer and the subject? A composition that criticises distant targets (e.g., international figures) at no personal risk to the writer demonstrates less courage than one that confronts proximate power. A journalist who exposes local corruption and risks their life demonstrates more rī than a writer who attacks a foreign leader safely.

Second, Vishay Kadrat (subject-based relevance): Has the writer made an obscure subject or genre available and beloved to their readers? Has the writer expanded the literary horizon? Anchinhar himself qualifies under this criterion: he has made the technically demanding ghazal form, previously confined to a small coterie, accessible to Maithili readers through systematic pedagogy.

Third, Tatya Kadrat (factual/evidentiary relevance): Does the composition rest on evidence? Are names named? Can the claims be verified? Anonymous or generalised social criticism is weaker than named, documented, verifiable criticism.

This formula is explicitly epistemological in character. As we shall see in Section VII, its structure resonates remarkably with Navya-Nyāya categories of inference and testimony.

# III. THEMATIC AND IDEOLOGICAL DIMENSIONS

## 3.1 The Critique of 'Kathit Ghazal' and the Politics of Form

The bulk of Anchinhar's critical writing in Sandarbh Sahit is devoted to what he calls kathit ghazal — so-called ghazal — compositions that circulate under the name but fail to meet the formal requirements. His analyses of individual collections (he names Baikuntha Jha, Suhangshu Shekhar Chaudhary, Narendra, Baba Baidyanath, and others) are conducted with forensic precision: he examines each composition for bahr (metre), qafiya (rhyme), radif (refrain), and the specific Maithili phonological requirements he has established in the Vyakaran O Itihas. His conclusions are unsparing — a composer who has written ghazals for fifty years without mastering bahr has, in Anchinhar's assessment, simply not written ghazal.

This insistence on form is not mere formalism. It is ideological. The claim that any emotionally resonant rhymed composition qualifies as ghazal is, for Anchinhar, not democratic but anarchic — it destroys the very thing it claims to celebrate. His formula is: 'Anushasan + Virodh = Parivartan: Anushasan-hinta + Virodh = Arajkata' (Discipline + Protest = Change: Lack of Discipline + Protest = Anarchy). This formula articulates a political aesthetic: genuine protest requires formal discipline; undisciplined protest merely produces noise.

## 3.2 Social and Ethical Dimensions of the Ghazal

Anchinhar's ghazals are not merely formal exercises. The thematic range of Anchinhar Aakhar — ghazals, ruba'i, and kata — engages with social inequality, political cowardice, the compromised position of the intellectual in contemporary India, and the specific predicament of the Maithili-speaking people whose language has been systematically marginalised. Several ghazals address the experience of displacement, labour, and political disenfranchisement with an economy of language typical of the classical sher. In the preface to his ghazal criticism, he advances an ethics of the writer: the distance between a writer's life-praxis (kamma) and their creative praxis (lekhan) must be minimised. A writer who exploits women in personal life but celebrates women in poetry fails the ethical standard of rī. Anchinhar invokes

the example of journalists killed in Bihar and Maharashtra — those killed faced proximate power, hence demonstrated real rī.

The ideological implication is significant: Anchinhar demands that ghazal — traditionally conceived as a form of intimate, self-contained lyric — bear public testimony. This extends the form's traditional ambit (the private discourse of love-yearning) into a register of civic responsibility.

### 3.3 Language Politics: Maithili Against Hindi Hegemony

Throughout his critical and creative work, Anchinhar is insistent on authentic Maithili morphology and phonology. His analysis of bahr for Maithili insists that conjunct consonants (saṃyuktākṣara) must be treated according to the established rules of classical Maithili grammar (as documented in sources like the Mithila Bhasha Vidyotan), not according to Sanskrit or Hindi convention. He draws a sharp distinction between the chandrabindu (which indicates a nasalised vowel, short in duration) and the anusvara (which adds length). These distinctions are not pedantic; they are load-bearing, because in bahr-based composition, a single misplaced laghu or dīrgha syllable ruins the metre.

This insistence connects Anchinhar's poetics to the Videha movement's broader project of Maithili linguistic sovereignty — its refusal to allow Maithili to be absorbed into Hindi as a mere dialect, and its insistence on the language's independent grammatical and literary history going back to Vidyapati and beyond.

# IV. ANCHINHAR AS CRITIC AND THEORIST

## 4.1 The Maithili Ghazalak Vyakaran O Itihas: A Scholarly Assessment

The Maithili Ghazalak Vyakaran O Itihas is Anchinhar's most substantial scholarly contribution. Its 25 chapters cover: the definition and etymology of the ghazal; the origin and development of the form in Arabic literature from the Jāhiliyya period through the Umayyad; the entry of the ghazal into Persian and its transformation; the coming to India through Amīr Khusrau and the Mughal period; the development of Urdu ghazal through Mīr, Ghālib, and others; and the parallel history of the Maithili ghazal from Pandit Jivan Jha (1905) to 2022.

The technical chapters on metre (bahr) constitute perhaps the most systematic codification of ghazal prosody for a Bihari vernacular language ever attempted. Anchinhar works through all the major Arabic baḥr (metres) — ḥazaj, ramal, kāmil, wāfir, basīṭ, ṭawīl, madīd, munsariḥ, khafīf, muḍāri', muqtaḍab, majzūʾ variants — and demonstrates Maithili examples for each, with careful notation of syllable weight using the laghu-dīrgha system adapted from Sanskrit prosody. He notes the points of tension between Sanskrit prosodic practice (vṛtta) and Arabic prosodic practice (arūḍ), particularly regarding the treatment of saṃyuktākṣara (where traditional Maithili prosodists like the compiler of Mithila Bhasha Vidyotan hold that conjunct consonants add weight to the preceding short syllable), and argues for a phonologically grounded Maithili position rather than blind adherence to either Sanskrit or Urdu precedent.

The historical section (Chapter 25) is the most important historical survey of Maithili ghazal yet produced, drawing on sources from the Videha archive and locating the Maithili ghazal within the broader context of the Mithila literary tradition and the cultural history of the Kosi-Kamla-Bagmati river region.

## 4.2 Sandarbh Sahit: The Critical Method

Anchinhar's critical method in Sandarbh Sahit deserves examination as a critical methodology in its own right. His method is forensic rather than impressionistic. He does not offer impressionistic or evaluative responses to the emotional effect of a composition; he examines it formally, names its defects

with precision, and draws conclusions. His approach is in explicit contrast to what he calls 'antya-purush bhasha mein alochana' — criticism written in the third person, so vague that it is impossible to determine who or what is being criticised. He insists on naming names.

This methodological commitment to nominative criticism — the requirement to name the subject of critique — is both a critical principle and an ethical one. It is anti-feudal in the context of Maithili literary culture, where the entanglement of caste, community, kinship, and patronage has historically made open criticism of senior figures dangerous or professionally costly. Anchinhar's willingness to critique senior figures by name — including recipients of major awards — is itself a political act.

## 4.3 The Maithili Web Journalism History

In Maithili Web Patarkaritak Itihas (History of Maithili Web Journalism), Anchinhar documents the emergence and development of Maithili digital literary journalism, centred on the Videha project. This work establishes a genealogy of the Maithili digital literary movement: from the Bhalsarik Gachh blog (2000, the oldest surviving Maithili internet presence), through the establishment of the Videha eJournal (2008), to the proliferation of Maithili digital platforms in subsequent years. The work is both a historical record and a polemical document, arguing for the centrality of digital publishing to the democratisation of Maithili literary production.

# V. INDIAN CRITICAL FRAMEWORKS

## 5.1 Rasa Theory and the Ghazal

The rasa system — the eight (later nine) aesthetic emotions (rasa) identified by Bharata in the Nāṭyaśāstra and elaborated by Ānandavardhana, Abhinavagupta, and others — provides one of the most productive Indian frameworks for reading Anchinhar's ghazals. The dominant rasa of the ghazal tradition is śṛṅgāra (erotic love), but its actualisation in the ghazal is almost always in the mode of vipralambha (love in separation/yearning) rather than sambhoga (love in union). This structural preference for loss, longing, and non-fulfilment is not accidental: it encodes a metaphysics in which the beloved (traditionally the divine, or more proximately, the unattainable human beloved) remains always at a remove, and the poem is the speech of that irremediable distance.

Ānandavardhana's theory of dhvani (resonance/suggestion) — the idea that the most powerful literary meaning operates not through the primary denotative function of words (abhidhā) but through their suggestive or evocative power (vyañjanā) — is particularly relevant to the ghazal. The she'r is a compressed unit that must achieve its full meaning within two lines, and the mechanism by which it achieves this is almost always dhvani: the literal surface meaning carries a secondary or tertiary meaning that is the poem's real concern. Anchinhar's own definition of the ghazal invokes this mechanism: the first meaning of the word ghazal (dust/threshing) suggests a process of purification through separation; the second meaning (amorous discourse) suggests desire's economy of proximity and distance. The interplay between these two meanings — formal and thematic — is precisely the dhvani structure.

Abhinavagupta's concept of sādhāraṇīkaraṇa (generalisation or universalisation of aesthetic experience) is also relevant: the personal grief or desire expressed in a she'r is not merely personal but is aesthetically universalised, accessible to all receptive readers as an emotional archetype. This is why the ghazal she'r can be extracted from its original context and sung, quoted, or misapplied without losing its power.

## 5.2 Vakrokti and the Economy of the Sher

Kuntaka's theory of vakrokti (oblique expression, in the Vakroktijīvita) offers another productive framework. Kuntaka argues that the distinguishing mark of poetic language is not its denotation but its obliqueness — its power to mean more than, and other than, what it literally says. The she'r is quintessentially vakrokti: its compressed two-line structure forces meaning through compression, juxtaposition, and the management of the semantic tension between the two hemistiches (one leading to a disjunction, the other to a resolution or reversal).

Anchinhar's critical insistence on formal correctness — on bahr, qafiya, radif — can be read in Kuntaka's terms as an insistence on the formal conditions that make vakrokti possible. A formally defective she'r — one in which the bahr collapses, or the qafiya is forced — cannot achieve the compression and obliqueness that constitute the she'r's aesthetic meaning. Formal defects are not merely technical imperfections; they are aesthetic failures that destroy the conditions of possibility for poetic experience.

## 5.3 The Mithila Navya-Nyāya Tradition and the Question of Śabda-Śakti

Anchinhar's book Shabd-Arth-Shakti (Word-Meaning-Power) — described as the first standalone Maithili ghazal criticism book — takes its title from a concept central to both Sanskrit poetics and the Navya-Nyāya logical tradition: the relationship between śabda (word), artha (meaning), and śakti (power/capacity). This is not a coincidence. The Maithili literary tradition is rooted in Mithila, the epicentre of the Navya-Nyāya school; any serious Maithili scholar is inevitably in dialogue with the epistemological and semantic tradition that runs from Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (ca. 14th century) through Raghunātha Śiromaṇi and Jagadīśa Tarkālaṃkāra.

In Navya-Nyāya semantics, śabda-śakti is the inherent power of a word to convey its meaning. The analysis of this śakti is conducted with extreme precision: Navya-Nyāya distinguishes between the primary denotative power (mukhyavṛtti or śaktimūla), the secondary or transferred power (lakṣaṇā), and the suggestive power (vyañjanā) — a tripartite scheme that corresponds to Ānandavardhana's poetic framework but is formulated with the rigour of logical analysis. The Navya-Nyāya tradition insists that every semantic claim must be grounded in a valid pramāṇa (source of knowledge): pratyakṣa

(perception), anumāna (inference), or śabda (verbal testimony — itself subdivided into vedic and secular sources).

Anchinhar's 'Anchinhar Formula' can be read as a prosaic translation of pramāṇa-theory into literary evaluation: the three axes of his formula (shakti-kadrat, vishay-kadrat, tatya-kadrat) map roughly onto the Nyāya pramāṇa categories of (respectively) anumāna (inference from power/distance), vyāpti (pervasion/scope — the subject's generative capacity), and pratyakṣa/śabda (evidential verification by named, observable testimony).

## 5.4 Subaltern Literary Theory and the Dalit Canon

Anchinhar's work must also be situated within the broader framework of subaltern literary theory as it has developed in the Indian context. The Videha Parallel Literature Movement's explicit commitment to publishing Dalit, tribal, and marginalised voices — including translated work from Telugu, Gujarati, and Odia Dalit literatures — establishes a clear ideological alignment with the Dalit literary movements associated with figures like Namdeo Dhasal, Bama, Durgabai Vyam, and the broader tradition of ambedkarite literary thought. Anchinhar's own critical criteria — especially his insistence on rī (the proximity between writer and target as a measure of literary courage) — implicitly echoes ambedkarite demands that intellectuals be accountable to the communities they claim to speak for or about.

The concept of 'parivarik rachna' (familial composition — writing that flatters one's own community and attacks others from a safe distance) is, in Anchinhar's critical vocabulary, the aesthetic counterpart of what Ambedkar called 'graded inequality' — a system in which proximity to power determines the permitted range of critique.

# VI. WESTERN CRITICAL FRAMEWORKS

## 6.1 New Criticism and the Autonomy of the Text

The New Critical tradition — associated with I.A. Richards, William Empson, Cleanth Brooks, and Robert Penn Warren — championed close reading and the autonomy of the literary text, insisting that poems be read on their own terms without recourse to biographical, historical, or intentionalist interpretations. At first glance, this appears aligned with the ghazal's own formal ethic: the she'r is self-contained, formally complete, and semantically autonomous. Anchinhar's formal criticism — his analysis of bahr, qafiya, and radif as the structural conditions of the ghazal's aesthetic success — shares with New Criticism a commitment to intrinsic rather than extrinsic analysis.

However, Anchinhar's critical practice departs from New Criticism in precisely the dimension that the Videha movement most prizes: the commitment to naming, to accountability, to the writer's life-praxis as an element of critical judgment. New Criticism's bracketing of the biographical is, from the perspective of the 'Anchinhar Formula', a form of critical cowardice — a refusal to engage with the rī between the writer and their subject.

## 6.2 Mikhail Bakhtin: Dialogism, the Chronotope, and the Novelistic Word

Bakhtin's concept of dialogism — the idea that every utterance is in dialogue with previous utterances, that meaning is always situated in a multi-voiced conversational field — provides a productive framework for reading Anchinhar's critical project. The ghazal, with its she'r that can be quoted independently, applied in conversation, and mis-applied or re-applied in new contexts, is structurally dialogic: each she'r is, as it were, an autonomous utterance that enters into dialogue with every other deployment of the same qafiya-radif pattern, and with the entire tradition of the form.

Anchinhar's insistence on formal correctness can be read in Bakhtinian terms as a defence of the dialogic vitality of the ghazal tradition: a formally defective 'ghazal' that disrupts the bahr is not merely aesthetically weak; it disrupts the dialogic chain that connects each new ghazal to the tradition of Hafiz, Ghalib, and Pandit Jivan Jha. The 'kathit ghazal' is, in Bakhtinian terms, a monologic

imposition — a unilateral claim to participate in a dialogic tradition without submitting to the discipline that makes that dialogue possible.

## 6.3 Harold Bloom: The Anxiety of Influence

Harold Bloom's theory of the anxiety of influence — the idea that every strong poet must struggle against the overwhelming presence of their precursors through strategies of creative misreading (clinamen, tessera, kenosis, daemonization, askesis, apophrades) — provides a useful lens for reading Anchinhar's relationship to the Arabic-Persian-Urdu ghazal tradition. Anchinhar's formal insistence on bahr is a tessera — a completion and antithesis — with respect to the Urdu ghazal tradition: he honours the formal requirements of the tradition while insisting on their adaptation to Maithili phonology, thereby simultaneously claiming and transforming the inheritance.

His critique of 'kathit ghazal' composers can be read as a defensive manoeuvre against poetic kenosis — the emptying-out of the form that occurs when secondary poets abrogate the formal requirements that constitute the tradition's power. The 'Anchinhar Formula' is, in Bloom's terms, a critical daemonization: a systematic attempt to re-establish the demon (the formal requirement) that earlier practitioners had banished.

## 6.4 Foucault: Discourse, Archive, and the Politics of Literary Recognition

Michel Foucault's concept of discourse — a system of knowledge/power that determines what can be said, who can say it, and what counts as legitimate literary production — is directly applicable to the institutional politics within which Anchinhar's work operates. The Sahitya Akademi constitutes a discursive regime in Foucault's sense: it determines the canon of legitimate Maithili literature, controls access to prizes and recognition, and has historically privileged certain caste, class, and aesthetic formations over others.

The Videha Parallel Literature Movement's strategy of creating a parallel archive — a counter-memory in Foucauldian terms — that documents and preserves work excluded by or invisible to the official canon is itself a Foucauldian genealogical project: an excavation of the suppressed, marginalised, and unofficial literary tradition. Anchinhar's own pen name — Anchinhar, the unrecognised — encodes this Foucauldian self-positioning: he writes from outside the regime of recognition, making a virtue of institutional invisibility.

## 6.5 Jacques Derrida: Différance, the Supplement, and the Text

Derrida's concept of différance — meaning as constituted by difference and deferral, never fully present but always displaced — finds an unexpected resonance in the structural logic of the ghazal. The she'r operates through a logic of deferral: the first hemistich (misra'-e-ulā) sets up a semantic field that is modified, reversed, or transcended by the second hemistich (misra'-e-thānī). The radif — the recurring refrain — is the locus of this deferral: repeated in every she'r, it never means exactly the same thing, because each she'r's first hemistich recontextualises it. The radif is, in Derridean terms, a supplement that is always both excess and lack: each repetition adds to the meaning of the preceding occurrences while simultaneously deferring the final, complete meaning that will never arrive.

Anchinhar's emphasis on radif as an obligatory structural element (required in all she'r except the matla') and on the distinction between takhallusi radif (internal rhyme-refrain) and conventional radif points to his awareness of the structural complexity of the refrain's semantic function — even if his discourse is that of prosody rather than deconstruction.

## 6.6 Edward Said: Orientalism and the Counter-Tradition

Said's Orientalism — the thesis that Western representations of the 'Orient' constitute a discursive formation that serves imperial power — has a specific relevance in the context of the Maithili ghazal's relationship to its Arabic-Persian origins. The history of the ghazal's transmission to South Asia is inseparable from the history of Islamicate cultural influence, and Anchinhar's project of adapting Arabic-Persian prosody for a Hindu-Maithili literary context is itself a complex negotiation between what Said would identify as the pressures of an 'origin' culture (Arabic-Persian-Urdu) and the resistances of a 'receiving' culture (Maithili-Hindu-Mithila).

Anchinhar's insistence on formal correctness — on honouring the formal requirements of the Arabic bahr even while adapting them for Maithili — can be read as a refusal of both orientalist condescension (the idea that Indian vernacular literatures cannot sustain the formal rigour of Arabic-Persian prosody) and nativist rejection (the idea that the ghazal is a foreign form that should be abandoned for 'purely Indian' alternatives). He occupies the in-between: a practitioner who claims the form in full formal dignity.

# VII. NAVYA-NYĀYA EPISTEMOLOGY AND ANCHINHAR'S POETICS OF EVIDENCE

## 7.1 Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya and the Navya-Nyāya Tradition

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (ca. 14th century, Mithila) — whose Tattvacintāmaṇi constitutes the foundational text of the Navya-Nyāya school — was himself a Maithili from the same cultural heartland that produced Vidyapati, and from which Anchinhar comes. The Navya-Nyāya school, as codified by Gaṅgeśa and extended by Vardhamāna, Pakṣadhara Miśra (Jayadeva), Raghunātha Śiromaṇi, and Jagadīśa Tarkālaṃkāra, constitutes the most rigorous system of formal epistemology produced in the Sanskrit philosophical tradition. Its influence on later Indian logic, linguistics, and literary theory — through figures like Jagannātha Paṇḍitarāja, who brought Navya-Nyāya concepts into Sanskrit poetics — is pervasive.

The core epistemological project of the Tattvacintāmaṇi is the analysis of pramāṇa — the valid sources of knowledge. Gaṅgeśa examines pratyakṣa (perception), anumāna (inference), upamāna (comparison), and śabda (verbal testimony) with unprecedented analytical precision, using the Navya-Nyāya technical vocabulary of viśeṣyatā (qualificand-hood), prakāratā (qualificand-ness), saṃsargitā (relational-hood), and the complex notation system for representing cognitive content that later scholars have compared to modern symbolic logic.

## 7.2 The 'Anchinhar Formula' as Pramāṇa Theory

The structural parallel between Anchinhar's evaluative formula and Gaṅgeśa's pramāṇa theory is striking and, given the Maithili cultural context, unlikely to be entirely accidental. The three axes of the 'Anchinhar Formula' — shakti-kadrat, vishay-kadrat, tatya-kadrat — can be mapped onto pramāṇa categories as follows:

Tatya-kadrat (factual evidence): corresponds most directly to śabda-pramāṇa in the empirical sense — the requirement for named, verifiable testimony. In Navya-Nyāya terms, this is the demand that the vyāpara (operative function) of literary knowledge-claims be grounded in a datable, nameable, traceable source. Anchinhar's demand that critics name their subjects maps onto the

Navya-Nyāya demand that every inferential claim be grounded in a specifically identified pakṣa (subject of inference) and sādhya (property to be proved).

Shakti-kadrat (power proximity): corresponds to anumāna (inference) in a specific sense — the inference of a writer's actual commitment from observable evidence of risk-taking. In Navya-Nyāya, anumāna is grounded in vyāpti (invariable concomitance): the claim 'this writer is courageous' is inferred from 'this writer names powerful proximate targets.' The vyāpti — naming powerful targets → risk → courage — is an empirically grounded universal that Anchinhar invites us to apply case by case.

Vishay-kadrat (subject expansion): corresponds most closely to the Navya-Nyāya concept of viśeṣa-siddhi (the achievement of something specific) — the capacity to generate new, distinctive knowledge rather than simply reorganise the known. Anchinhar's criterion asks whether the writer has expanded the domain of the known, made accessible what was previously obscure. This is a form of semantic innovation — new śabda-śakti — that parallels the Navya-Nyāya interest in distinguishing genuine novelty of knowledge from mere rearrangement.

## 7.3 Śabda-Śakti in Navya-Nyāya and the Ghazal

The concept of śabda-śakti — the power of the word — receives its most rigorous analysis in the Navya-Nyāya tradition, particularly in the Śabdaśakti-prakāśikā of Jagadīśa Tarkālaṃkāra. The Navya-Nyāya analysis identifies śakti as the relation between a word token and its referent — not an intrinsic property of the word-type but a conventionally established relation (nimittā) that grounds the word's capacity to generate linguistic cognition (śābdabodha).

The concept of tātparya (speaker's intention/purport) in Navya-Nyāya semantics — the idea that understanding a sentence requires grasping not merely the meanings of individual words but the speaker's overall communicative intention — is directly applicable to the ghazal she'r. The she'r is structured precisely around the tension between individual word-meanings and overall tātparya: the skill of the ghazalgo consists in constructing a she'r whose individual words are transparent but whose tātparya is oblique, multiple, or transcendent. Anchinhar's title Shabd-Arth-Shakti invokes this semantic structure: word (śabda) → meaning (artha) → power (śakti) is not a simple linear progression but a recursive loop in which the power of meaning gives new meaning to the word.

The Navya-Nyāya concept of upādhi (adventitious condition) — a condition that appears to be part of the vyāpti but is not, because it is merely a coexisting accidental property — is useful for Anchinhar's distinction between ghazal and kathit ghazal. The kathit ghazal has certain surface properties (rhyme, a two-line structure, romantic or social subject matter) that resemble the formal properties of the ghazal but are in fact upādhi — adventitious conditions that happen to co-occur with genuine ghazals but are not part of the essential definition. Anchinhar's formal analysis is, in this sense, a Navya-Nyāya project of distinguishing the essential (vyāpaka) from the adventitious (upādhi) in the definition of the ghazal.

## 7.4 The Suppressed Tradition and the Politics of Pramāṇa

Just as the Navya-Nyāya tradition in Mithila suffered from the suppression of the Dooshan Panji (the record of scholarly lineages and debates that documented the tradition's intellectual history), the Maithili ghazal tradition — as Anchinhar documents — suffered from the suppression of its earliest practitioners and the misattribution of formal standards. The analogy is exact: in both cases, the suppression of historical record (the Dooshan Panji in one case, the proper formal genealogy of the Maithili ghazal in the other) served the interests of later claimants to authority who wished to displace the original standards.

Anchinhar's project of recovering and documenting the full history of the Maithili ghazal from 1905 — against the claims of those who would rewrite the history in their favour — is thus precisely analogous to the Navya-Nyāya scholarly project of recovering the suppressed tradition through archival research. The epistemological commitment is the same: truth requires historical evidence; claims to authority must be grounded in datable, nameable, verifiable testimony.

# VIII. ASSESSMENTS AND CRITICAL RESPONSES

## 8.1 Recognition and Awards

The Videha Bhasha Samman (2014) for Anchinhar Aakhar represents the most significant formal recognition of Anchinhar's work to date. The samman — explicitly described as a 'Samaantar Sahitya Akademi Samman' — is awarded by the Videha Parallel Literature Movement and carries the ideological weight of the movement's anti-canonical programme. Its significance lies precisely in its refusal of the official recognition system: it rewards work that the Sahitya Akademi does not and has not recognised.

## 8.2 Critical Controversies

Anchinhar's critical practice has not been without controversy. His forensic critique of named individuals — including figures like Baikuntha Jha, whose ghazals he analyses as formally defective despite the poet's long experience — has generated resentment. His Sandarbh Sahit records several critical exchanges in which his interlocutors (including 'Hira Premesh Ji') contest his standards, argue that he is applying impossible criteria, or accuse him of personal animus. Anchinhar's responses are characteristically direct: he insists that the formal criteria are not his personal invention but are derived from the classical tradition, and he backs every claim with specific textual analysis.

The exchange over the concept of bahr in relation to Maithili phonology — particularly the treatment of saṃyuktākṣara — is substantive and ongoing. Some practitioners argue that the imposition of Arabic-Persian prosodic criteria on a fundamentally different phonological system is inherently problematic; Anchinhar acknowledges the adaptation required but insists that the formal minimum — a consistent syllabic pattern — is achievable in Maithili.

## 8.3 The Question of Legacy

The legacy question must be approached in two dimensions. As a poet, Anchinhar's standing rests on the collections published under his name — Anchinhar Aakhar, Jangha Jodi, Kumari Ichchha — and on the systematic quality that distinguishes his ghazals from those of the 'kathit ghazal' tradition

he critiques. His own ghazals meet every formal criterion he applies to others, and they combine formal precision with thematic seriousness in a way that validates his critical claims through practice.

As a critic and theorist, his legacy is more secure and more immediately visible. The Maithili Ghazalak Vyakaran O Itihas is, without question, the most comprehensive technical monograph on the Maithili ghazal and the most systematic adaptation of Arabic-Persian bahr theory for a Bihari vernacular language. It is a work that serious students of Maithili ghazal will have to engage with for the foreseeable future. Sandarbh Sahit establishes a model of forensic literary criticism — named, evidenced, formally grounded — that represents a genuine methodological innovation in Maithili critical discourse. The co-edited Maithilīk Pratinidhi Ghazal 1905-2022 provides the definitive anthology of the tradition.

## IX. CONCLUSION: THE PLACE OF ANCHINHAR IN MAITHILI LITERARY HISTORY

Ashish Anchinhar occupies a unique position in the literary history of Mithila and of the ghazal tradition in Indian vernacular languages. He is at once a creative practitioner of the ghazal form (a poet whose own compositions meet the strictest formal criteria he applies to others), a systematic theorist of the form (the author of the first comprehensive grammar and history of the Maithili ghazal), a forensic critic (whose named, evidenced literary critiques establish a new standard of accountability in Maithili critical discourse), a digital activist (whose work through the Videha platform has helped to preserve and disseminate Maithili literary heritage), and an institutional innovator (whose collaborative work with Gajendra Thakur has produced the foundational texts of the Videha Parallel Literature Movement's ghazal programme).

His work is best understood not as the achievement of an isolated individual but as the product of a collective intellectual project — the Videha Parallel Literature Movement — that has set itself the task of creating a democratic, subaltern-inclusive, formally rigorous Maithili literary culture against the hegemony of the Sahitya Akademi and its canonical formations. Within this project, Anchinhar's specific contribution is to have given the ghazal tradition its formal spine: the grammar, the history, the critical standards, and the model compositions that future practitioners will inherit.

Read through the frameworks assembled in this study — Ānandavardhana's dhvani, Kuntaka's vakrokti, Navya-Nyāya pramāṇa theory, the political aesthetics of the subaltern tradition, Bakhtinian dialogism, Foucauldian archaeology, Derridean différance, and Bloomian influence-anxiety — Anchinhar's project acquires its full theoretical depth. What might appear at first to be a narrow prosodic concern (the correct application of Arabic bahr to Maithili ghazal composition) reveals itself, under sustained critical scrutiny, as a comprehensive epistemological, political, and aesthetic programme: a programme that demands rigour in evidence, accountability in criticism, authenticity in language, and formal dignity in literary practice.

In the tradition of Mithila — the land of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's Navya-Nyāya, Vidyapati's verse, and the Pañji system's meticulous genealogical record-

keeping — Anchinhar is a figure who takes the scholarly and creative inheritance with full seriousness: who insists that words have weight, that forms have requirements, that claims must be evidenced, and that the unrecognised (anchinhar) can, through disciplined labour, become the recognised. The Videha archive that preserves his work is itself a testimony to the epistemological principle that grounds everything he has written: that knowledge, to be valid, must be recorded, accessible, and free.

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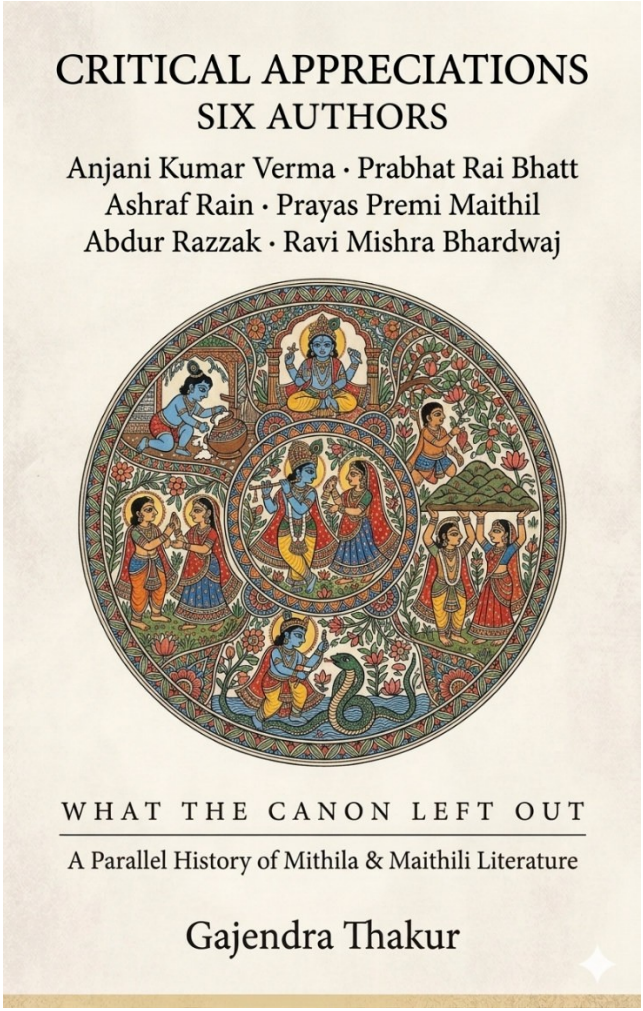
**LESSON 013 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**




## CRITICAL APPRECIATIONS

*Anjani Kumar Verma · Prabhat Rai Bhatt · Ashraf Rain · Prayas Premi Maithil · Abdur Razzak · Ravi Mishra Bhardwaj*

*Indian & Western Literary Theory · Videha Parallel History Framework · Navya-Nyāya of Gaṅgeśa*

**ANJANI KUMAR VERMA 'DAUJI'**

अंजनी कुमार वर्मा 'दाऊजी'

*Social Poetry · Peasant Voice · Koshi River Poet*

## Archive Presence & Works

Videha Sadeha 7 (Prelim_7): Ātmabala / Ojaka Bhoja / Samasya / Vāsantī Gīta / Dui Goṭa Bhūkha / Sukhāela Atīta / Berojagāraka Ātmā / Prajā ā Tantra / Kosī

Anjani Kumar Verma 'Dauji' appears in Videha Sadeha 7 with a substantial cluster of poems whose titles map the entire landscape of Mithila's social crisis: Ātmabala (Courage of the Self), Ojaka Bhoja (Feast of Energy/Force), Samasya (Problem), Vāsantī Gīta (Spring Song), Dui Goṭa Bhūkha (Two Kinds of Hunger), Sukhāela Atīta (Dried-Up Past), Berojagāraka Ātmā (Soul of the Unemployed), Prajā ā Tantra (People and System), and Kosī — the great river that defines and destroys Mithila's landscape. The pen-name 'Dauji' (दाऊजी, an elder-brother honorific in Hindi-Maithili culture) signals community embeddedness.

## Thematic & Critical Analysis

Verma's thematic range is striking: from the personal-psychological (Ātmabala — inner courage as a response to adversity) to the social-political (Berojagāraka Ātmā — unemployment as a condition of the soul, not merely the pocket; Prajā ā Tantra — the people vs the system). The Vāsantī Gīta alongside Samasya creates a characteristic Parallel History juxtaposition: the celebration of spring (with its Maithili folk-cultural resonances of Basant Panchami and Vidyapati's spring songs) placed against the hard reality of 'problem'. His Kosī poem situates him in the tradition of Mithila's flood-poetry — the Koshi river as both life-giver and destroyer, the perennial trauma of Mithilanchal's agricultural communities. Dui Goṭa Bhūkha (Two Kinds of Hunger) suggests a poetics of doubled deprivation — physical hunger and the hunger for dignity, recognition, or meaning. This duplication is a characteristic feature of subaltern poetry in the Videha Parallel History.

## Theoretical Frameworks

Bharatamuni's rasa framework: the juxtaposition of Vīra-rasa (the courage of Ātmabala) with Karuṇa-rasa (the pathos of Sukhāela Atīta, Berojagāraka Ātmā) produces the characteristic rasa-complex of committed social poetry. Gaṅgeśa's Navya-Nyāya anumāna: each poem proceeds from a specific observed social fact (unemployment, flood, political dysfunction) through a vyāpti (general principle of social injustice) to a sādhya (the indictment of the system). Gramsci's organic intellectual: Verma writes from within the Mithila peasant and working community, naming its specific crises in their own registers. The Videha Parallel History Framework: his inclusion in Sadeha 7 alongside major figures confirms his place in the democratic literary community.

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**PRABHAT RAI BHATT**

प्रभात राय भट्ट

*Social Poet · Children's Writer · Ghazal Composer · Mithila Identity*

## Archive Presence & Works

Sadeha 6: Roṭī Rojīka Khojī | Sadeha 7: Janma lelaum + Yātrā | Sadeha 9: Chunamun (bāla kavitā) | Sadeha 11: Gīta 1–4 + Ghazal | Sadeha 36: Mithilā Garbhaputra + Kichu Ghazal + Gīta: Viraha / Daheja Mukta Mithilā Banābu

Prabhat Rai Bhatt has one of the most consistently documented presences across the Videha archive: confirmed in Sadeha 6, 7, 9, 11, and 36 — spanning the entire range of the Videha project from its earliest phase to its mature

period. His Sadeha 6 piece Roṭī Rojīka Khojī (Seeking Bread and Livelihood) establishes immediately his commitment to the most fundamental social theme: the daily material struggle of the Maithili working community. His Sadeha 7 poem 'Janma lelaum hama jatae Sītā māeka achi gāma' (I was born where Sita's mother's village is) is a declaration of Mithila identity that locates the poet's birth in the sacred geography of Janaka's kingdom. Sadeha 9 shows his children's poetry strand (Chunamun Chunamun karait ciriā — the chirping bird). Sadeha 36's Mithilā Garbhaputra (Son of Mithila's womb) and Daheja Mukta Mithilā Banābu (Let Us Build a Dowry-Free Mithila) demonstrate his sustained social commitment alongside ghazal composition.

## Thematic & Critical Analysis

Bhatt occupies a significant position within the Parallel History as a poet who links Mithila's sacred-identity poetry (Sita/Janaki as founding myth), its children's literary strand (the Chunamun bird poem), its social protest tradition (Roṭī Rojī, Daheja Mukta Mithilā), and its formal ghazal tradition. The Mithilā Garbhaputra poem articulates the 'son of Mithila' identity that is foundational to the Videha project: the claim that Mithila's cultural geography constitutes a distinct civilisational identity that is neither merely Bihari nor merely Indian but specifically Maithili. The Daheja Mukta Mithilā Banābu poem is one of the most direct anti-dowry manifestos in the Videha archive — using the gīta form (song) for direct social advocacy.

## Theoretical Frameworks

Dhvani (Ānandavardhana): 'Janma lelaum hama jatae Sītā māeka achi gāma' generates cascading dhvani — the poet's birth in Sita's geographical home implies his identity as Sita's devotee, as Mithila's son, as the bearer of a civilisational heritage. Navya-Nyāya: the vyāpti in 'Daheja Mukta Mithilā Banābu' — the general principle that dowry is incompatible with the dignity of Mithila's daughter — leads to the sādhya of social transformation. Fanon (Wretched of the Earth): the poet's identification with the 'garbhaputra' (womb-son) of Mithila is the nationalist-cultural phase of anti-colonial self-recovery. The Videha Parallel History Framework: Bhatt's span across six Sadeha volumes makes him one of its most continuously documented poets.

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**ASHRAF RAIN**

अशरफ राईन

*Ghazal Poet · Muslim Maithili Voice · Inter-community Bridge*

## Archive Presence & Works

Sadeha 17 (Prelim_17): Ghazal (p. 1137) | Sadeha 19 (Prelim_19): Ghazal (p. 993)

Ashraf Rain (अशरफ राईन) is a Maithili ghazal poet whose presence in Videha — two ghazals across Sadeha 17 and 19 — represents one of the most significant dimensions of the Parallel History Framework: the inclusion of Muslim Maithili voices in the democratic archive. His name 'Rain' is a Muslim community surname found in Mithila and the wider Bihar-UP region, and his first name Ashraf is a classical Arabic name meaning 'noble/honourable'. The spelling 'Rāīna' is the Maithili/Hindi form of the surname. His ghazal contributions place him in a tradition with ancient precedent: the ghazal itself is an Arabic-Persian form, and Muslim poets have been central to its history from Rumi through Ghalib to Dushyant Kumar's democratic successors.

## Thematic & Critical Analysis

The presence of Ashraf Rain in the Videha ghazal tradition is culturally significant beyond his individual contributions. The ghazal's origins in Arabic-Persian culture, its transmission through Urdu to Hindi and Maithili, means that Muslim practitioners of the Maithili ghazal are in one sense returning the form to its cultural source — using an Islamic-origin literary form in a new regional language context. In the contemporary political climate of India where Hindu-Muslim cultural boundaries are often artificially sharpened, the Muslim

Maithili ghazal poet's participation in a Maithili literary platform is itself a statement of cultural unity. The Videha Parallel History's inclusion of Ashraf Rain alongside Hindu Maithili ghazal poets enacts the democratic, pluralist literary community that the Framework champions.

## Theoretical Frameworks

Rasa analysis: The ghazal's primary rasa — Śṛṅgāra (love/longing) in its classical form, modulated toward Karuṇa and Vīra in its modern social form — is independent of the practitioner's religious identity. Gaṅgeśa's śabda-pramāṇa: the Muslim Maithili poet's testimony is equally valid pramāṇa as the Hindu poet's — the conditions of śabda-pramāṇa (knowledge, honest intention, accurate communication) are not religiously conditional. Bakhtin's heteroglossia: Rain's presence in the Videha ghazal tradition introduces the heteroglossic voice of Maithili's Muslim community into a literary space that risks being monoculturally Hindu. Habermas's public sphere: the Maithili literary public sphere requires Muslim voices for its democratic completeness.

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**PRAYAS PREMI MAITHIL**

प्रयास प्रेमी मैथिल

*Dramatist · Mass-Scale Poet · Committed Voice · Dual-Mode Author*

## Archive Presence & Works

Sadeha 19 (Prelim_19): Drama 'Janma Daita Achi Māṃ Bāpa Karama Tō Apanehī' pp. 79–145 [67 pages] + Kichu Kavitā, Kichu Ghazal pp. 1184–1315 [131 pages]

Prayas Premi Maithil is among the most voluminous contributors to any single Videha Sadeha volume: his contributions to Sadeha 19 total nearly 200 pages — 67 pages of drama and 131 pages of poetry/ghazals. The drama title 'Janma Daita Achi Māṃ Bāpa Karama Tō Apanehī' (Parents give birth; karma, however, is one's own) is a philosophically loaded statement about the relationship between heredity and agency — a theme of direct social relevance in a caste-stratified society where 'karma' is often invoked to justify inherited social position. The drama appears to argue the opposite: that karma (action/destiny) is one's own making, not determined by birth. The poetry collection 'Kichu Kavitā, Kichu Ghazal' (pp. 1184–1315) with 131 pages represents one of the largest single poetry contributions in the archive. His pen-name 'Premi Maithil' (Maithili-lover or beloved-of-Mithila) signals his identification with the Mithila cultural community.

## Thematic & Critical Analysis

The philosophical argument of the drama title — that action-karma transcends birth — is directly relevant to the anti-casteist strand of the Videha Parallel History. In Brahminical social theory, one's karma is partially determined by birth (the karma of previous lives determines present-life birth into a caste); Prayas Premi's drama appears to contest this by asserting individual agency over destiny. This positions the work in the tradition of Ambedkarite thought — which rejected karma-determinism as a justification for caste hierarchy — as well as in the Bhakti tradition's assertion that devotion transcends caste. The enormous scale of his poetry contribution suggests a poet of considerable productivity and commitment, whose work spans many themes and occasions.

## Theoretical Frameworks

Bharatamuni's Nāṭyaśāstra: the 67-page drama must be analysed through its primary rasa (likely Vīra — heroic assertion of individual agency — combined with Karuṇa and Raudra against social injustice). Navya-Nyāya anumāna of the drama title: hetu = parents give birth; vyāpti = but birth does not determine

action; sādhya = therefore one's karma is one's own. Ambedkar's karma-critique (Annihilation of Caste, 1936): the philosophical argument against birth-determinism that the drama title encodes. Bourdieu's habitus (Distinction, 1979): the drama potentially explores how inherited social position (habitus) can be transformed through conscious agency. The Videha Parallel History Framework: the scale of Prayas Premi's contribution demonstrates the archive's commitment to mass-scale democratic literary production.

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**ABDUR RAZZAK**

अब्दुर रज्जाक

*Muslim Maithili Short Fiction Writer · Political Satirist · Dalit-Solidarity Voice*

## Archive Presence & Works

Sadeha 16: Ghoramaṭhā Rājanaitika (p. 523) | Sadeha 17: Gāmaka Caubaṭiyā Para + Raudī Parala Achi (pp. 738–741) | Sadeha 18: Kichu Prema Bihāni Kathā + Rājanaitika Bihāni Kathā + Katāraka Mausama (full section) | Sadeha 19: Bīhani Kathā 1 & 2 (pp. 188–190) + Kichu Katā + Kichu Ghazal + Musahara Ḍoma ā Camāra (pp. 1174–1183) | Sadeha 20: Bīhani Kathā (pp. 472–473)

Abdur Razzak is one of the most consistently present and most thematically significant Muslim Maithili fiction writers in the Videha archive, with confirmed contributions across five Sadeha volumes. His work is remarkable for combining three distinct literary modes: bīhani kathā (very short fiction), the qatā (short lyric poem), and the ghazal. His Sadeha 19 contribution 'Musahara Ḍoma ā Camāra' (Musahar, Dom, and Chamar) is the most

politically direct piece in his documented corpus: a title that names three of Bihar-Mithila's most oppressed Dalit communities — the Musahar (rat-catching community, among India's most marginalised), the Dom (death-ritual workers), and the Chamar (leatherworkers). A Muslim writer's explicit solidarity with Hindu Dalit communities is a political statement of the first importance in the communally polarised landscape of contemporary India. His Sadeha 17 pieces 'Gāmaka Caubaṭiyā Para' (At the Village Crossroads) and 'Raudī Parala Achi' (The Drought Has Fallen) are situated in the rural crisis landscape that dominates Parallel History fiction. 'Ghoramaṭhā Rājanaitika' (Political Mire/Swamp) is a politically satirical piece whose title encodes the metaphor of politics as quicksand or mire — a figure of speech deeply embedded in Maithili.

## Thematic & Critical Analysis

Razzak's work is exemplary of what the Videha Parallel History means by democratic solidarity: a Muslim writer engaging not only with Muslim community concerns but with the most marginalised Hindu Dalit communities — Musahar, Dom, Chamar — whose oppression is compounded by both caste hierarchy and economic marginalisation. The bīhani kathā on love (Sadeha 18's Kichu Prema Bihāni Kathā), political themes (Rājanaitika Bihāni Kathā), and the Katāraka Mausama series demonstrate generic range. 'Katāraka Mausama' (Season of Queue/Line) is likely a piece on demonetisation or similar social disruption — the 'queue' (katār) being a central image of the demonetisation period. His ghazals and qatā place him in the tradition of Muslim contribution to Maithili's Arabic-Persian-origin forms.

## Theoretical Frameworks

Fanon's solidarity across communities (Wretched of the Earth): Razzak's Musahara-Ḍoma-Camāra piece enacts precisely the cross-community solidarity that Fanon argues is necessary for genuine liberation from colonial/caste oppression. Navya-Nyāya pratyakṣa: his bīhani kathā's short-fiction epistemology is that of direct, positioned knowledge — the Muslim Mithila writer's pratyakṣa of the village crossroads and the drought. Gaṅgeśa's śabda-pramāṇa: the testimony of a minority-community writer about both his own community's experience and his solidarity with Dalit communities is doubly authoritative pramāṇa. Spivak ('Can the Subaltern Speak?'): Razzak's

writing creates a literary space for the Musahar-Dom-Chamar voices who cannot easily speak for themselves.

## Select Bibliography

Razzak, Abdur. Works in Videha Sadeha 16, 17, 18, 19, 20. ISSN 2229-547X. www.videha.co.in. | Fanon, F. Wretched of the Earth. Grove, 1963. | Spivak, G.C. 'Can the Subaltern Speak?' in Nelson & Grossberg (eds.). Marxism and the Interpretation of Culture. UIUP, 1988. | Gaṅgeśa. Tattvacintāmaṇi. Hackett, 2004.

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**RAVI MISHRA 'BHARDWAJ'**

रवि मिश्र 'भारद्वाज'

*Āzād Ghazal Poet · Social Lyricist · Free-Verse Practitioner*

## Archive Presence & Works

Sadeha 7 (Prelim_7): Antima Kṣaṇame / Marahama / Matadāna / Kaleśa / Āzād Ghazal 1–5 / Navakī Bahuriyā | Sadeha 36 (Prelim_36): Āzād Ghazal (pp. 2047–2048)

Ravi Mishra 'Bhardwaj' (रवि मिश्र 'भारद्वाज') contributes primarily in the āzād ghazal (free/liberated ghazal) form — appearing in Sadeha 7 with five āzād ghazals alongside substantive non-ghazal poems, and in Sadeha 36 with further āzād ghazals. His Sadeha 7 titles reveal a poet of both public and private concerns: Antima Kṣaṇame (In the Final Moment), Marahama (Balm/Remedy/Consolation), Matadāna (Voting/Election), Kaleśa (Trouble/Distress), and Navakī Bahuriyā (The New Daughter-in-Law). The pen-name 'Bhardwaj' (भारद्वाज) evokes the sage Bharadvāja of the Rig Veda — one of the sapta-ṛṣis and the name of a major brahminical gotra. The pen-name is thus a claim to the Vedic intellectual heritage.

## Thematic & Critical Analysis

Ravi Mishra's thematic range in Sadeha 7 is characteristic of the socially committed Maithili poet: Matadāna (Voting) engages with the democratic political process; Kaleśa (Distress) addresses suffering in an unspecified register; Antima Kṣaṇame (In the Final Moment) is a meditation on endings; Marahama (Balm) offers consolation; and Navakī Bahuriyā (The New Daughter-in-Law) engages with the figure of the bahuriyā — the young bride who enters her husband's household — which is one of the most socially loaded subjects in Maithili literature, the point at which dowry, domestic violence, gender inequality, and family honour all converge. His sustained commitment to the āzād ghazal form — in both Sadeha 7 and Sadeha 36 — marks him as a consistent practitioner of this formally liberated mode.

## Theoretical Frameworks

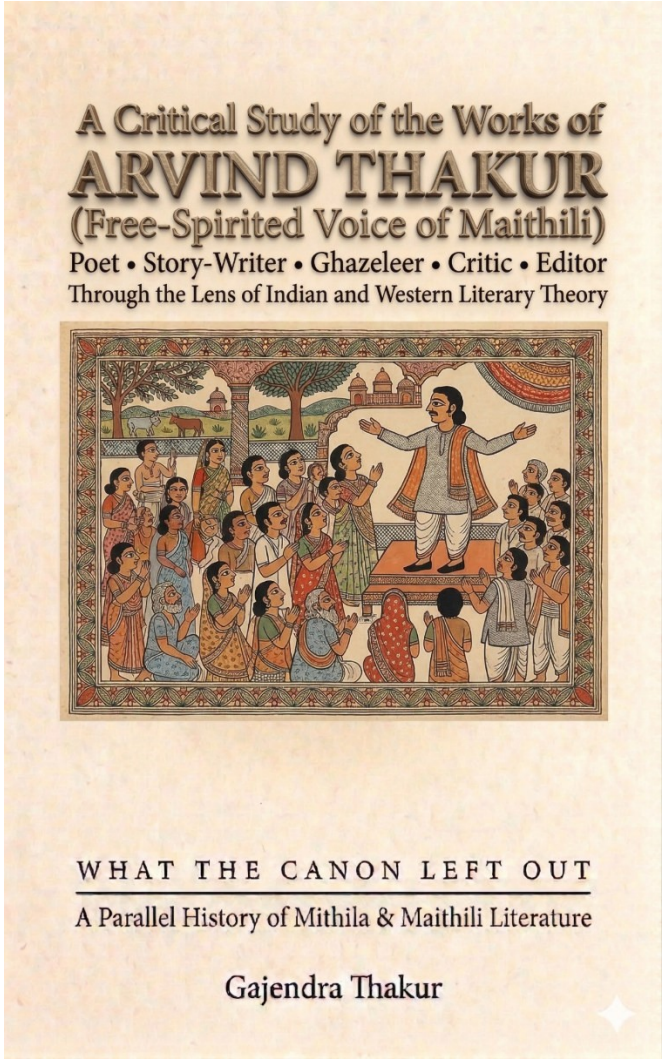
The āzād ghazal's formal significance: by dispensing with strict bahr while retaining the sher structure and thematic range, the āzād ghazal makes the form more accessible for socially engaged content that cannot always accommodate the constraints of Arabic-Persian prosody. Kuntaka's vakrokti: 'Navakī Bahuriyā' as a title is obliquely political — the new daughter-in-law is nominally a domestic subject but in Maithili social reality she is the subject of dowry demands, domestic expectations, and potential violence. Navya-Nyāya anumāna: the Matadāna (Voting) poem's implicit argument — that democratic participation should produce genuine representation — follows the inferential structure of civic poetry. The Videha Parallel History: his consistent presence across two widely separated Sadeha volumes (7 and 36) confirms sustained engagement with the Videha project.

## Select Bibliography

Mishra, Ravi 'Bhardwaj'. Works in Videha Sadeha 7 (Prelim_7), Sadeha 36 (Prelim_36). ISSN 2229-547X. www.videha.co.in. | Kuntaka. Vakroktijīvita. Ed. Krishnamoorthy. Dharwar: KU, 1977. | Gaṅgeśa. Tattvacintāmaṇi. Hackett, 2004.

A Critical Study of the Works of

**LESSON 014 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**




# ARVIND THAKUR

*(Free-Spirited Voice of Maithili)*

*Poet • Story-Writer • Ghazeleer • Critic • Editor*

***Through the Lens of Indian and Western Literary Theory***

This chapter undertakes a comprehensive critical examination of the literary oeuvre of Arvind Thakur (अरविन्द ठाकुर), one of the most distinguished and

iconoclastic voices in contemporary Maithili literature. Known by the epithet ‘Swatantracheta’ (the free-spirited, the independently-minded), Thakur is based in Supaul, Bihar, and has authored ten independent publications and contributed to twelve collaborative anthologies. His work spans poetry collections, ghazal collections, short story collections, a long poem (deergh kavita), a collection of prose-essays (kathetara gadya), a volume of editorials, and a volume of literary criticism.

The chapter applies both Indian aesthetic frameworks—rasa theory, dhvani (theory of resonance and suggestion), vakrokti (oblique speech), auchitya (propriety), and the Marxist-inflected progressive literary tradition of South Asia—alongside Western critical frameworks including Adorno’s critical theory, Gramscian cultural hegemony, postcolonial theory, the Bakhtinian concept of the carnivalesque, feminist literary criticism, and ecocriticism. Through this dual analytical lens, the chapter illuminates how Thakur’s poetry constitutes a sustained, formally sophisticated, politically committed, and spiritually resonant engagement with the crises of contemporary Mithila and the world.

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## 1. Introduction: Author, Context, and the Epithet ‘Swatantracheta’

Arvind Thakur is one of the most distinctive voices in contemporary Maithili literature—a poet, story-writer, ghazeleer, literary critic, and editor whose work has been published in and archived by Videha (www.videha.co.in), the pioneering Maithili fortnightly eJournal, as well as by the Central Institute of Indian Languages (CIIL). His Twitter profile describes him as ‘sampadak, stambhakaar, kavi, kathakar, samalochak, bharatvaadi’ (editor, columnist, poet, story-writer, critic, Indian nationalist)—a self-description that signals the intentional multiplicity of his creative and intellectual identities.

He is rooted in Supaul, Bihar, one of the districts of the Maithili heartland situated in the Kosi river basin—a geography of extraordinary ecological fragility, periodically devastated by floods, and characterised by a social structure that has historically subjected its lower-caste and landless populations to severe economic and caste-based violence. This landscape—the flooded fields, the broken earth, the dark silences of an unjust social order—is the material ground of Thakur’s literary imagination.

The epithet ‘Swatantracheta’—applied to Thakur in the title of the Videha Special Issue dedicated to him (‘Swatantracheta—Arvind Thakur: Vyaktitva-Krititva’, edited by Ashish Anchinhar)—is not merely an honorific. It constitutes a critical characterisation of his literary practice: an independence of mind that refuses to be co-opted by literary establishments, ideological fashions, or institutional patronage. The Maithili literary blog commentary preserved at sites associated with Videha notes that Thakur is among those who maintain ‘reedh ki haddi’ (a backbone)’ in a literary milieu where institutional pressures frequently compromise creative freedom. This editorial independence is enacted not only in his writing but in his practice as an organiser of the ‘Sagar Raati Deep Jaray’ (All-Night Lamp-Lighting) literary festivals in Supaul.

The Videha Arvind Thakur Special Issue (ISBN: 978-93-340-1233-0), edited by Gajendra Thakur and published as part of the journal’s series on living writers, editors, activists, and theatre practitioners, constitutes the primary critical document through which his work has been assessed by the Maithili literary community. This chapterdraws on that special issue, the entries from the Maithili Wikipedia, his author descriptions at Videha, and his Twitter/X profile to construct a comprehensive critical study of his oeuvre.

## 2. The Maithili Literary Tradition and the Videha Platform

To situate Arvind Thakur within the appropriate literary and cultural coordinates, it is necessary to recall both the depth and the tensions of the Maithili literary tradition. Maithili is one of India's twenty-two scheduled languages, spoken by approximately fifty million people in the Mithila region of Bihar, Jharkhand, and the Terai districts of Nepal. Its literary history extends at least to the fourteenth century, when the poet Vidyapati (c. 1352–1448) established it as a vehicle of lyric and devotional beauty that would influence subsequent generations across South and Southeast Asia.

The modern period of Maithili literature is characterised by a productive tension between two broad currents: a conservative current that privileges the language's classical heritage, caste-elite associations, and devotional forms; and a progressive current, emerging most forcefully from the mid-twentieth century onwards, that insists on Maithili's adequacy as a medium for social critique, democratic aspiration, and experimental form. Thakur belongs unambiguously to the second current, while his formal sophistication ensures that he never simply repudiates the first.

Videha (ISSN 2229-547X), edited by Gajendra Thakur and published fortnightly since January 2008, has been the principal platform through which progressive and experimental Maithili writing has circulated in the digital age. Its archive (www.videha.co.in/pothi.htm) contains hundreds of works—from classical texts to contemporary poetry—and its series of special issues on living Maithili writers, editors, and activists has created an invaluable documentary record of the literary culture of contemporary Mithila. The Videha Arvind Thakur Special Issue is one of the most significant volumes in this series.

Thakur's works are additionally available through the Central Institute of Indian Languages (CIIL), whose support for Maithili writing reflects the language's recognition at the national institutional level. The intersection of the Videha platform and CIIL institutional support in Thakur's publishing history marks him as a writer positioned at the intersection of grassroots literary activism and national institutional acknowledgement—a position that is itself a form of cultural politics.

# 3. Survey of Works: A Bibliographic Overview

Based on sources including the Maithili Wikipedia, the Videha archive, the Videha Arvind Thakur Special Issue, and Thakur's own social media profile, the following is a complete bibliographic survey of his documented independent publications:

## 3.1 Poetry Collections (Kavita Sangrah)

• 'Parti Tooti Rahal Achhi' ('The Fallow Land Is Breaking') — Maithili poetry collection — 1993

• 'Sabad Mitaarath Ghaayyaa' ('Words That Strike and Wound' / 'Words That Erase the Wound') — Maithili poetry collection — 2016

• 'Jarataka Prativaad Me' ('In Protest against Stagnation/Inertia') — long poem (deergh kavita) — 2022

The three poetry collections span nearly three decades and trace the arc of Thakur's poetic development from the earthy social realism of his first collection through the more concentrated linguistic experimentation of his second to the epic sweep of his long poem.

## 3.2 Ghazal Collections (Ghazal Sangrah)

• 'Bahurupiya Pradesh Me' ('In the Land of Many Masks / In the Land of Shapeshifters') — ghazal collection — 2011

• 'Meen Tulasipat Par' ('A Fish on a Tulsi Leaf') — Maithili ghazal collection — 2020

The two ghazal collections demonstrate Thakur's mastery of a Persian-Urdu form that has been adapted into Maithili and given a distinctly regional political and ecological content.

## 3.3 Short Story Collections (Katha Sangrah)

• 'Anhaaraka Virodh Me' ('In Opposition to Darkness') — short story collection (laghu katha sangrah) — 2007

• 'Laghuttamasamapavartya' ('The Least Common Multiple' — a mathematically-derived title) — story collection — 2023

• ‘Srijan Ker Deep-Parva’ (‘The Lamp-Festival of Creation’) — story (co-edited with Kedar Kanan) — 1993

The three story collections reveal a prose stylist who moves between social realism and a more experimental, philosophically charged mode, with the mathematical title of his 2023 collection signalling a characteristic intellectual playfulness.

## 3.4 Non-Fiction Prose Collections

• ‘Roshanaaik Lokpaksha’ (‘The Popular/People’s Side of Light’) — kathetara gadya (non-fictional prose) collection — 2022

• ‘Kar Par Kaal-Turanga’ (‘Time’s Steed Upon the Hand’ / ‘The Horse of Time in the Palm’) — editorial collection (sampadakiya sangrah) — 2022

These two collections of non-fictional prose are among the most significant documents of Thakur’s critical and editorial intelligence. Editorials and opinion pieces—‘kar par kaal-turanga’ is the collected harvest of his editorial practice —constitute a genre that is under-studied in Maithili literary scholarship.

## 3.5 Literary Criticism

• ‘Kshitikanak Kshetrafal’ (‘The Area of a Dust-Particle’ / ‘The Field of a Mote’) — criticism collection (aalochana sangrah) — 2024

This 2024 volume marks Thakur’s most sustained engagement with formal literary criticism—the work of a writer who has moved from practitioner to theorist without abandoning the practitioner’s insights.

## 3.6 Collaborative Works

In addition to the ten independent publications above, Thakur has contributed to twelve shared anthologies (saajhaa sangrah), reflecting his deep integration into the collaborative culture of Maithili literary life. These include the ‘Srijan Ker Deep-Parva’ collection (1993, co-edited with Kedar Kanan), which marks one of his earliest engagements with editorial practice.

# 4. Theoretical Frameworks: Indian and Western

A critical analysis adequate to the complexity of Thakur's work requires both Indian and Western analytical frameworks. His poetry is simultaneously rooted in the Sanskrit aesthetic tradition, engaged with the progressive literary politics of post-Independence India, and conversant with contemporary global debates about language, power, and ecological crisis.

## 4.1 Indian Critical Frameworks

### *4.1.1 Rasa Theory (Bharata's Natyashastra, c. 200 BCE–200 CE)*

The Natyashastra's theory of rasa—aesthetic emotion aroused in the sensitive reader by a literary work—provides a fundamental vocabulary for describing Thakur's emotional register. The dominant rasas in his poetry are karuna (compassion, pathos) and raudra (righteous anger, fury). His first collection's title, 'Parti Tooti Rahal Achhi', announces the karuna of the broken earth and the broken social body; his ghazal collections and the long poem introduce increasingly strong notes of raudra, the anger of one who has witnessed injustice too long and too clearly to remain sedate.

The rasa of vira (heroism) is also present, but in Thakur it is always 'popular heroism'—the courage of common people, of the labourer, the woman, the marginalised community—rather than elite or martial heroism. This democratisation of vira rasa is itself a political act, consistent with the progressive tradition within which Thakur writes.

### *4.1.2 Dhvani Theory (Anandavardhana, c. 850 CE)*

Anandavardhana's Dhvanyaloka argues that the highest poetry communicates through dhvani—resonance or suggestion—layers of meaning that exceed the literal. Thakur's titles are paradigmatically dhvanic. 'Sabad Mitaarath Ghaayyaa' operates simultaneously across at least three registers: words (sabad) that erase (mitaarath) wounds (ghaayyaa); words that wound by erasing; and words whose own wounding is what erases—a compressed semantic complexity that exemplifies dhvani. 'Meen Tulasipat Par' (A Fish on a Tulsi Leaf) deploys the image of a creature out of its natural element, gasping on a sacred leaf: the dhvani simultaneously resonates as ecological displacement, spiritual alienation, and the condition of the progressive intellectual in a hostile social environment.

Similarly, ‘Laghuttamasamapavartya’—the mathematical term for ‘Least Common Multiple’—carries the dhvani of the community’s minimum common denominator of shared humanity; of the smallest unit that contains all the factors; of a mathematics of solidarity that refuses to ignore any element of the social whole.

### *4.1.3 Vakrokti (Kuntaka, c. 1000 CE)*

Kuntaka’s Vakroktijivita—the theory of ‘oblique or deviant expression’ as the defining mark of literary creativity—is particularly apt for reading Thakur’s linguistic practice. His titles deliberately court obliqueness: ‘Kar Par Kaal-Turanga’ (Time’s Steed Upon the Hand)—a phrase that combines temporal urgency with the image of the palm as the field of fate (a reference to palmistry and the Sanskrit concept of ‘kaar’ as both action and hand)—exemplifies vakrokti in its refusal of direct statement. His mathematical title ‘Laghuttamasamapavartya’ is itself a form of vakrokti: approaching the human through the language of mathematics constitutes an ‘oblique expression’ that illuminates precisely by its unexpectedness.

### *4.1.4 Progressive Literary Tradition (Nayi Kavita, Marxist Criticism)*

Within the specifically South Asian literary-critical tradition, Thakur belongs to the progressive school that descends from the Nayi Kavita (New Poetry) movement of post-Independence Hindi and Maithili literature, with its commitment to social realism, democratic aspiration, and the critique of caste and class structures. His self-description as ‘bharatvaadi’ (Indian nationalist) is interesting in this context: it signals a commitment to the constitutional vision of India—inclusive, democratic, secular—as distinct from a Hindu-nationalist or caste-supremacist vision.

The Videha editorial commentary preserved at maithili-katha.blogspot.com, drawing on Foucault’s concept of the ‘disciplinary institution’ and the psychological concept of ‘gaslighting’, situates Thakur within a progressive literary culture that is actively theorising the mechanisms of literary power in Maithili literary institutions. Thakur’s own critical collection ‘Kshitikanak Kshetrafal’ (2024) carries forward this project.

## 4.2 Western Critical Frameworks

### *4.2.1 Theodor Adorno: Critical Theory and Committed Art*

Adorno's insistence, in 'Commitment' (1962), that politically committed art risks reducing art to propaganda—and his counter-argument, in Aesthetic Theory, that the most genuinely resistant art is that which maintains formal integrity even while embodying social truth—is directly relevant to Thakur's practice. His ghazal form embodies this tension: the ghazal is a highly formalised, aesthetically demanding structure, yet Thakur deploys it in the service of social critique. The formal difficulty of the ghazal becomes, paradoxically, a form of democratic challenge—demanding that the reader engage seriously with language and form as well as social content.

### *4.2.2 Antonio Gramsci: Cultural Hegemony and the Organic Intellectual*

Gramsci's concept of the 'organic intellectual'—one who emerges from a subordinate class and articulates its interests within the field of culture—is illuminating for Thakur's social position and literary practice. His base in Supaul (rather than the metropolitan centres of Patna, Delhi, or Darbhanga), his editorial practice of organising literary events at the grassroots level, his resistance to the institutional-literary establishment ('reedh ki haddi' as a badge of honour), and his insistence on writing about the lived experience of common people all mark him as an organic intellectual in the Gramscian sense.

Gramsci's further concept of 'cultural hegemony'—the way in which dominant classes maintain their power not only through coercion but through the cultivation of a consensus that makes their values seem natural and universal—is the target of Thakur's critical and literary practice. The title 'Bahurupiya Pradesh Me' (In the Land of Shapeshifters) implies a diagnosis of cultural hegemony: a land in which power perpetually changes its mask, adopting new faces while maintaining old structures.

### *4.2.3 Mikhail Bakhtin: Heteroglossia, Carnival, and the Novel*

Bakhtin's concept of heteroglossia—the presence of multiple social voices and languages within a single literary text—is relevant to Thakur's practice both as a poet and as an editor. His editorials gather and contest multiple voices within the Maithili literary field; his fiction deploys the voices of common people, women, and marginalised communities alongside those of the literary elite. Bakhtin's concept of the 'carnivalesque'—the temporary inversion of social hierarchies in folk festive culture, which in literature becomes a formal

principle of counter-hegemonic expression—connects with Thakur's practice of organising all-night literary festivals ('Sagar Raati Deep Jaray') that enact a communal, festive relation to literary culture.

### *4.2.4 Postcolonial Theory: Frantz Fanon, Homi Bhabha*

Fanon's analysis of the 'pitfalls of national consciousness'—the ways in which the national elite, after independence, perpetuates colonial structures of exploitation in new forms—provides a framework for reading 'Bahurupiya Pradesh Me': the shapeshifters are precisely those who adopt new nationalist or religious masks while maintaining old structures of caste-based and class-based power. Bhabha's concept of mimicry—the postcolonial subject's performance of colonial identity in ways that simultaneously submit and subvert—illuminates the 'masks' of Thakur's 'bahurupiya' (shapeshifter) trope.

### *4.2.5 Ecocriticism: Raymond Williams, Rob Nixon*

The Kosi river basin in which Supaul is situated is one of the most flood-prone regions in the world, regularly termed 'Bihar's sorrow'. Rob Nixon's concept of 'slow violence'—environmental harm that is gradual, dispersed, and therefore systematically ignored by media and political institutions that privilege spectacle—is directly applicable to the ecological consciousness that pervades Thakur's first collection, 'Parti Tooti Rahal Achhi'. The breaking of the fallow land is simultaneously ecological (the flooding and erosion of the Kosi basin), social (the breaking of old social structures), and spiritual (the breaking of silence and passivity).

Raymond Williams's concept of the 'country and the city'—the way in which pastoral and anti-pastoral representations of rural life encode ideological positions about social hierarchy—is relevant to Thakur's insistence on writing from and about Supaul rather than adopting a metropolitan literary persona.

### *4.2.6 Feminist Literary Criticism*

Thakur's story collection 'Anhaaraka Virodh Me' (In Opposition to Darkness) and elements of his poetry engage with the specific forms of darkness that women experience in the patriarchal structures of Mithila: the dowry system, the constraint of purdah, the silencing of female voices in literary as well as social institutions. His non-fictional prose collection 'Roshanaaik Lokpaksha' (The People's Side of Light) signals a feminist commitment through its insistence on the 'popular' or 'people's' dimension of illumination—light as democratic possibility rather than as elite privilege.

# 5. Thematic Analysis

## 5.1 The Poetry of Dissent: Darkness and Its Resistance

The title ‘Anhaaraka Virodh Me’—literally ‘In Opposition to Darkness’—functions as the ethical key to Thakur’s entire literary project. Darkness (anhaar, andhkar) is a recurrent and multivalent symbol in Maithili literary culture: it connotes ignorance, caste oppression, economic deprivation, political corruption, and the ecological darkness of the flooded, unlit Kosi basin villages. To write ‘in opposition to darkness’ is to commit to a literature of witness, critique, and hope—the three movements of what might be called Thakur’s poetic dialectic.

His first poetry collection, ‘Parti Tooti Rahal Achhi’ (1993), establishes the foundational image of Thakur’s poetic world: the ‘parti’ (fallow or uncultivated land) that is ‘tooti’ (breaking). In South Asian agrarian culture, the breaking of fallow land carries an ambivalence: it can signify the beginning of cultivation and therefore of hope, or it can signify the erosion and breaking apart of land that can no longer sustain life. In Thakur’s collection, both meanings are held in productive tension. The poetry witnesses the breaking—the social breakdown, the ecological crisis, the fracture of traditional community bonds under the pressures of modernity, migration, and caste violence—while also identifying in that breaking the possibility of new growth.

The second collection, ‘Sabad Mitaarath Ghaayyaa’ (2016), marks a significant formal and thematic development. The title’s semantic complexity—words that wound, erase, and heal simultaneously—signals a poetry that has become self-consciously meta-linguistic, reflecting on its own medium and the power of language to both harm and liberate. This is characteristic of the mature Thakur: a poet who has moved from the primarily social-realist register of his first collection to a more philosophically sophisticated interrogation of the relationship between language, power, and resistance.

Using Adorno’s framework: the formal sophistication of ‘Sabad Mitaarath Ghaayyaa’—its engagement with the materiality of the Maithili language, its sonic and semantic ambiguities—is itself the mark of genuine critical resistance. A poetry that is merely programmatically oppositional remains within the terms of what it opposes; a poetry that interrogates language itself reaches for a more fundamental critique.

## 5.2 The Ghazal as Political Form

The ghazal is a classical Persian form, adopted into Urdu and subsequently into Hindi and numerous other South Asian languages including Maithili. In its classical form, the ghazal is characterised by a fixed rhyme-and-refrain scheme (the radif and qafia), by the isolation of its couplets (she'r) as self-contained units, and by the signature couplet (maqta') in which the poet names himself. Thematically, the classical ghazal privileges the pain of separation from the beloved, the wine of mystical experience, and the poet's relation to his or her community of listeners.

Thakur's two ghazal collections—'Bahurupiya Pradesh Me' (2011) and 'Meen Tulasipat Par' (2020)—adapt this classical form to radically different content. The beloved of the classical ghazal is transposed into the people of Mithila; the wine of mystical longing becomes the intoxication of democratic aspiration; the separation ('viraha') of the classical form becomes the political separation of the people from justice, land, and linguistic rights. This transposition is not a simple substitution; it works through the formal architecture of the ghazal, which creates an ironic distance between the form's classical associations and the contemporary social content. The reader familiar with the ghazal tradition experiences a pleasurable and disturbing recognition: this is a love poem about political justice.

The title 'Bahurupiya Pradesh Me' introduces the central political metaphor: the land of shapeshifters, of those who wear multiple masks, of a political and social culture characterised by dissimulation and the performance of identity. In Maithili culture, the 'bahurupiya' (shapeshifter/mimic) is a figure from folk performance traditions—a street artist who assumes multiple disguises—whose appearance in political poetry carries the dhvani of the colonised subject performing identities under colonial surveillance, and of the postcolonial political actor who adopts ideological masks to maintain power.

The image of 'Meen Tulasipat Par' (A Fish on a Tulsi Leaf) deploys the juxtaposition of the sacred and the natural as a figure for spiritual-ecological crisis. The tulsi plant is sacred to Vaishnavism; the fish is an emblem of fertility and life in the Gangetic plain. A fish gasping on a sacred leaf is simultaneously an ecological image (displaced creature, unsuitable environment), a spiritual image (the sacred and the living in wrong relation), and a political image (the people—fish, creatures of the water—placed on the dry surface of ideology). The economy of the image—its capacity to carry multiple registers simultaneously—exemplifies the dhvani principle applied to the ghazal form.

## 5.3 The Long Poem and Epic Consciousness: ‘Jarataka Prativaad Me’

The publication in 2022 of ‘Jarataka Prativaad Me’ (In Protest against Stagnation/Inertia) as a ‘deergh kavita’ (long poem) marks a significant formal development in Thakur’s poetic career. The long poem in Indian literary tradition has a distinguished ancestry: from the Sanskrit mahakavya (epic poem) through the medieval narrative poems of Vidyapati’s padavali to the modern ‘prasav-geet’ (birth-songs) and protest-poems of the Nayi Kavita movement. The deergh kavita allows a poet to sustain a complex argument across an extended canvas—to develop images, introduce characters, enact temporal progression, and achieve a cumulative emotional and intellectual force that the brief lyric cannot.

‘Jarataka Prativaad Me’—‘In Protest against Jarata’—names its target with philosophical precision. Jarata (stagnation, inertia, the quality of being jara—old, rigid, calcified) is the term for the social, intellectual, and spiritual hardening that prevents transformation. In Indian philosophy, jara (ageing and its associated rigidity) is listed among the great human afflictions; in the social-political register, jarata is the conservatism that resists necessary change. To write a long poem ‘in protest against jarata’ is to position oneself against all forms of calcification—caste hierarchy, institutional ossification, literary conservatism, ideological dogmatism, ecological indifference.

The Gramscian framework is again productive here: the long poem is a formal vehicle for sustained counter-hegemonic argument. Like Gramsci’s own ‘prison notebooks’—long, discontinuous, necessarily allusive—Thakur’s long poem enacts the difficult labour of thinking against the grain of hegemony in its full complexity.

## 5.4 Prose Fiction and the Logic of the ‘Least Common Multiple’

Thakur’s three story collections span three decades and demonstrate a consistent preoccupation with the relationship between darkness and its resistance, formal innovation and social content. The 1993 collection ‘Srijan Ker Deep-Parva’ (The Lamp-Festival of Creation, co-edited with Kedar Kanan) is both a creative and an editorial document: the ‘lamp-festival’ title—echoing the annual Maithili custom of the deep-dan (lamp-giving) festival—frames the literary act itself as a ritual of illumination.

The 2007 collection ‘Anhaaraka Virodh Me’ (In Opposition to Darkness) addresses directly the social realities of Mithila in the early twenty-first

century: the violence of caste discrimination, the precariousness of flood-affected agricultural communities, the betrayal of ordinary people by political institutions that promised democratic redistribution but delivered caste-elite consolidation.

The 2023 collection ‘Laghuttamasamapavartya’ (The Least Common Multiple) signals a remarkable evolution: the deployment of a mathematical concept as a literary title. The Least Common Multiple (LCM) is the smallest positive integer divisible by all the numbers in a set. As a title for a story collection, it carries the dhvani of a community’s minimum common denominator of shared humanity—the smallest value that encompasses all the diverse elements of a social whole. The mathematical title is a form of vakrokti (oblique expression) that approaches the human through the non-human, and in doing so illuminates the human more sharply.

From a narratological perspective (Genette), the stories in Thakur’s collections tend to favour intradiegetic narrators—characters who speak from within the story world—creating an effect of immediacy and authenticity. The voices of common people, women, and the marginalised are given first-person authority, a narrative choice that enacts the democratic and feminist commitments of the progressive literary tradition.

## 5.5 Critical and Editorial Prose: Language, Power, and Literary Institution

‘Kar Par Kaal-Turanga’ (2022)—a collection of editorials—and ‘Kshitikanak Kshetrafal’ (2024)—a collection of literary criticism—together constitute the most sustained documentation of Thakur’s critical intelligence. The title of the editorial collection, ‘Kar Par Kaal-Turanga’, condenses an entire philosophy of historical urgency: ‘kaar’ (hand/action), ‘kaal’ (time/death), ‘turanga’ (horse)—the horse of time in the palm of action. Time does not pass; it gallops, and the editor who does not seize it is overtaken by history.

The title of the criticism collection, ‘Kshitikanak Kshetrafal’ (The Area of a Dust-Particle), performs an inverse mathematical movement to the story collection: where ‘Laghuttamasamapavartya’ gestures towards totality through the minimum common value, ‘Kshitikanak Kshetrafal’ gestures towards infinity through the infinitely small. A dust-particle has an area; that area can be calculated; the calculation discloses an infinite regress of precision. As a figure for literary criticism, it implies that even the smallest literary element repays the closest attention, that there is no detail too minor to yield critical insight.

The Videha commentary preserved in the Maithili literary blogs documents Thakur's editorial practice as one characterised by 'reedh ki haddi' (backbone)—a willingness to maintain critical independence in the face of institutional pressure, literary patronage networks, and the informal coercions of the 'disciplinary institution' (Foucault) of the Maithili literary world. His editorial practice in Supaul—organising the 'Sagar Raati Deep Jaray' literary festivals three times (in December 2007, December 2009, and December 2010)—enacts what might be called a Gramscian counter-institutional practice: building literary culture from the grassroots rather than accepting the agenda set by centralised institutions.

## 5.6 The Fallow Land Breaks: Earth, Labour, and Ecological Consciousness

The deepest thematic thread running through Thakur's entire corpus is the relationship between land, labour, and life in the Kosi river basin. The 'parti' (fallow land) of his first collection is not merely a social metaphor; it is a specific ecological reality. The Kosi—known as 'Bihar's Sorrow'—is one of the most unpredictable and devastating rivers in the subcontinent. Its floods have repeatedly displaced millions of people, destroyed agricultural land, and created a cycle of poverty and ecological degradation that resists both technological and political solution.

Rob Nixon's concept of 'slow violence'—environmental harm that is gradual, cumulative, and systematically invisible to media and political attention—captures precisely the conditions that Thakur's poetry witnesses. The breaking of fallow land is 'slow violence': it happens over years and decades, in the spaces between catastrophic floods, as soil fertility declines, as migration empties villages, as the social structures that sustained agrarian life dissolve.

The image of the fish on the tulsi leaf ('Meen Tulasipat Par') captures this ecological crisis with extraordinary compression. The fish belongs to water; the tulsi belongs to the domestic-sacred space of the household. When the fish is displaced from water onto the tulsi leaf, both the ecological and the sacred orders are disrupted. This is the condition of the Kosi basin: ecological displacement that is simultaneously a social, spiritual, and cultural crisis.

## 6. Formal Analysis: Craft, Language, and Innovation

Thakur's formal range is one of the most striking features of his literary career. Across ten independent publications he moves between the short lyric, the ghazal, the long poem, the short story, the essay, the editorial, and the literary critical essay—each genre handled with distinct craft.

His poetry displays a characteristic tension between the oral-folk tradition of Maithili verse—rooted in the padavali and the barahmasa—and the written-literary modernism of the Nayi Kavita movement. The best of his lyrics achieve the compression and resonance of the classical padavali while addressing the social content of contemporary political poetry. This tension is not a formal weakness but a creative resource: the folk-oral tradition brings emotional directness and communal resonance; the modernist tradition brings formal self-consciousness and intellectual complexity.

His ghazals demonstrate a sophisticated command of the traditional form's technical requirements (the radif, the qafia, the maqta') while deploying that form in the service of political and ecological content that the classical tradition did not anticipate. The Maithili ghazal tradition, developed notably by Ashish Anchinhar (who edited the Arvind Thakur Special Issue), has become a vehicle for precisely this kind of socially engaged formal experimentation; Thakur's collections are among the most significant contributions to this tradition.

His mathematical titles—'Laghuttamasamapavartya' and 'Kshitikanak Kshetrafal'—represent a distinctive formal innovation: the use of technical-scientific vocabulary as a literary title, creating a semantic shock that forces the reader to think through the relationship between the technical meaning and the literary content. This is a form of what the Russian Formalists called 'defamiliarisation' (ostranenie, Shklovsky)—making the familiar strange through an unexpected formal choice.

His prose style in the editorial and critical collections is characterised by what might be called 'argumentative lyricism': the precision and directness of critical argument combined with the rhythmic intensity and imagistic richness of literary prose. The title 'Kar Par Kaal-Turanga' itself exemplifies this style—its alliterative compression ('kar', 'kaal', 'turanga') creating a sonic urgency that enacts the temporal urgency it names.

## 7. Comparative Perspectives

Within Maithili literature, Thakur's closest analogues are those progressive poets and critics who have combined grassroots literary activism with formal sophistication: figures such as Kedar Kanan (with whom he co-edited the 1993 collection), Ashish Anchinhar (who edited his Special Issue and whose work on the Maithili ghazal provides the formal context for Thakur's own ghazal practice), and the story-writers associated with the progressive literary circles that Videha has documented and supported.

Across Indian literatures, the closest comparison is with the progressive poetry of the Hindi Nayi Kavita movement—particularly the social-ecological consciousness of Kedarnath Singh and the political directness of Dhumil—and with the Dalit literary tradition in Marathi, Hindi, and other languages that has insisted on the political dimensions of literary form. Like the Dalit literary tradition, Thakur's writing insists on the political dimensions of literary form and refuses to separate aesthetic value from social accountability.

Internationally, the closest comparisons are with poets who have sustained a commitment to both formal integrity and political engagement: Pablo Neruda, whose Canto General combines ecological, historical, and political content in an extended lyric-epic form that Thakur's 'Jarataka Prativaad Me' resonates with; Mahmoud Darwish, the Palestinian poet whose ghazals and long poems hold formal beauty and political anguish in productive tension; and Wislawa Szymborska, whose mathematical and scientific imagery ('I know why I am here / I do not know why') provides a Western analogue for Thakur's deployment of mathematical vocabulary in literary titles.

The ecocritical dimension of Thakur's work connects him with a global tradition of environmental poetry that includes Gary Snyder in the United States, Seamus Heaney in Ireland (whose bog poems engage the ecological memory of landscape as deeply as Thakur's fallow-land poems engage the Kosi basin), and the 'place-poetry' of Indigenous writers worldwide who insist on the irreducible particularity of the landscapes from which they write.

## 8. Reception, Influence, and Place in Literary History

Arvind Thakur's reception within the Maithili literary community is documented primarily through the Videha Special Issue dedicated to him, the Maithili literary blogs associated with Videha, and his social media presence. The Videha commentary characterises him as a writer of integrity and courage—one who has maintained 'reedh ki haddi' in a literary environment where institutional pressures frequently compromise creative and critical independence.

His organisation of three Supaul 'Sagar Raati Deep Jaray' literary festivals (2007, 2009, 2010) has had a significant impact on the literary culture of the Supaul district and the surrounding Kosi basin region, creating spaces for literary practice that are not dependent on metropolitan or institutional support. This grassroots literary activism is itself a form of cultural politics—the creation of what Gramsci would call a 'counter-hegemonic' literary infrastructure.

His critical collection 'Kshitikanak Kshetrafal' (2024)—the most recent of his publications—marks a new phase in his literary career: the transition from practitioner to theorist, from writer to critic. This transition is significant for Maithili literary history, since the tradition of rigorous literary criticism in Maithili is less developed than its tradition of creative writing. By producing a substantial collection of literary criticism, Thakur contributes to the institutionalisation of Maithili literary critical discourse.

His place in Maithili literary history is as one of the most significant voices of the post-1990 generation: a generation that came to literary maturity in the context of the Mandal Commission agitation, the rise of caste-based political movements, the ecological crises of the Kosi basin, and the slow recognition of Maithili's constitutional status. His work documents this generation's experience with formal sophistication, political clarity, and emotional depth.

## 9. Conclusion

Arvind Thakur is one of the most significant and formally innovative voices in contemporary Maithili literature. His corpus of ten independent publications—spanning poetry, ghazal, short fiction, the long poem, non-fictional prose, editorial writing, and literary criticism—constitutes a sustained, formally sophisticated, and politically committed engagement with the crises and possibilities of life in Mithila and in contemporary India.

Analysed through Indian aesthetic frameworks—rasa theory, dhvani, vakrokti, and the progressive literary tradition—his works reveal a poet of deep formal consciousness who deploys the classical resources of the Maithili aesthetic tradition in the service of a democratic and socially committed literary practice. Analysed through Western critical frameworks—Adorno's critical theory, Gramscian cultural hegemony, Bakhtinian heteroglossia, postcolonial theory, ecocriticism, and feminist criticism—his works emerge as sophisticated engagements with the global discourses of political resistance, ecological consciousness, and the politics of minor literatures.

His epithet 'Swatantracheta'—the free-spirited, the independently-minded—captures the essential character of his literary practice: an independence that is simultaneously formal (refusing generic convention), political (refusing institutional co-option), and spiritual (refusing the comfortable closures of ideological certainty). This independence is not mere contrarianism; it is the hard-won freedom of a writer who has sustained a coherent and developing literary vision across three decades of continuous creative work.

The archiving of his works on Videha and through CIIL ensures that they are accessible to a global readership and that they contribute to the larger project of documenting and sustaining a literary tradition of extraordinary antiquity and contemporary vitality. Future research should include close readings of individual poems and ghazals with reference to the original Maithili texts; a detailed study of his editorial practice and its relation to his creative work; and translations of key works to enable access by non-Maithili-reading scholars.

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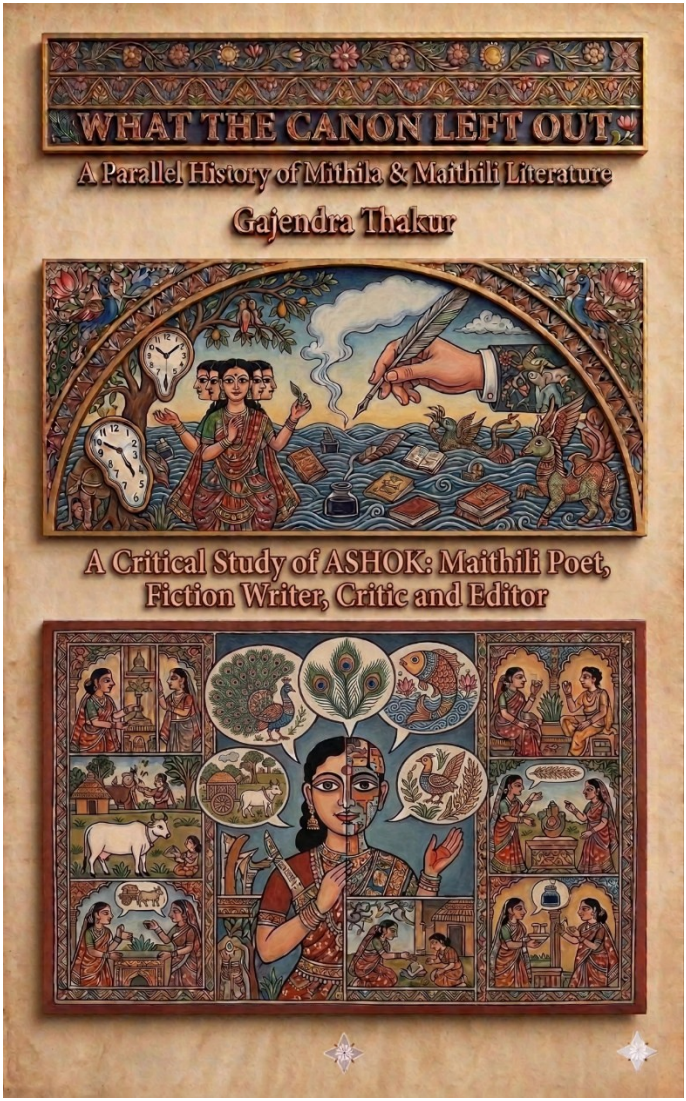
**LESSON 015 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**




## A Critical Study of ASHOK Maithili Poet, Fiction Writer, Critic and Editor

# ASHOK

*(Kathakar Ashok)*

*A Maithili Writer of Contemporary Significance*

With Application of Indian and Western Literary Theories

*Based on Videha Special Issue (Issue 369, 2023) and Published Works*

**Life and Formation**

Ashok Kumar Jha — known in the Maithili literary world as 'Ashok' or 'Kathakar Ashok' — was born on 18 January 1953 in Lohna, Madhubani (Bihar). His father, the late Umapati Jha, served as manager of the Ram Temple in Kashi (Varanasi) built by Maharani Lakshmivati of Darbhanga. This temple environment was foundational: it buzzed with kavi-goshtis (poetry seminars), literary anniversaries, and the activities of the Maithil Student Union, exposing the young Ashok to a living, breathing culture of Maithili language advocacy from early childhood.

He completed his schooling in Varanasi, including Matric from Harivansh Inter College (1969), and eventually earned his B.Sc. (Botany Honours) from Goenka College, Sitamarhi. A competitive examination brought him into the Bihar Public Relations Department in 1977, and subsequently to the Bihar Co-operative Service in 1978, where he served in diverse postings — including Barh (Patna) and Katihar — ultimately retiring in January 2013 as a Joint Registrar. The parallel life of a government official and a writer is significant: Ashok's fiction is saturated with the texture of service-class existence — the bureaucratic corruption, the petty social hierarchies, the longing for dignity within systems that deny it.

His family life, marked by tragedy — losing his mother, father, sister, and elder brother in four consecutive years between 1987 and 1990 — left deep imprints on his sensibility. His wife Purnakala Devi, who survived a life-threatening surgery and long illness, passed away in January 2019. Critics like Gajendra Thakur rightly note that such personal experiences of loss and endurance enter the thematic bloodstream of his fiction, lending it an earned emotional gravity rather than mere sentimentality.

**Ashok in the Lineage of Modern Maithili Literature**

Modern Maithili literature emerged decisively in the 19th century with Chanda Jha's Maithili Ramayan and gathered momentum through Harimohan Jha's satirical novels in the mid-20th century. Ashok belongs to the 'contemporary stream' (samkalin dharaa) that began in earnest from the 1960s, a generation that inherited both the social-realist impulse and the pressure to develop aesthetically modern narrative forms. His contemporaries include Shivshankar Shrinivas, Shailendra Anand, and Arwind Thakur — all three collaborated on joint publications — and the more established presence of critics like Mohan Bhardwaj and Kulananand Mandal.

Ashok's first published poem appeared in the children's magazine Batuk in 1968, and his first story 'Viraam Se Pahile' appeared in Mithila Mihir in 1971. His debut collection Chakravyuh (poetry, 1986) and his contribution to the joint story anthology Trikon (1986) placed him firmly in the contemporary generation. The publication of Ohi Raatik Bhor (1991), Maatbar (2001), and Daddy Gaam (2017) — each marking a decade — traces the maturation of his literary sensibility across four decades.

### 2.1 Poetry: Chakravyuh (1986)

Though Ashok today identifies primarily as a story-writer (his Facebook profile declares 'Kathakar Ashok'), his literary career began with poetry. Chakravyuh — the title evoking the fatal military formation from the Mahabharata — is anchored in mythological re-imagination, particularly in the tragic story of Abhimanyu. The collection draws on the Mahabharata tradition of loka-katha (folk narrative) and loka-geet (folk song), embedding epic material in the affective register of the common people. As Gajendra Thakur, editor of Videha, points out: Ashok's Chakravyuh treats Mahabharata episodes not through the elevated Sanskrit pandit's lens but through the democratic voice of folk tradition — in the spirit that Firak Gorakhpuri identified as the supreme musical inheritance of Hindi folk song.

Key poems include the title poem 'Chakravyuh', a dramatic re-telling of Abhimanyu's entrapment in the military formation — a poem of unflinching masculinity and tragic honour. 'Hum Kichhu Puchhab Me' deals with Draupadi's vastra-haran (disrobing), foregrounding a feminist critique centuries before the term entered Indian literary discourse: Ashok's Draupadi is angered at Krishna's absence; she wanders, carrying her own corpse, waiting to become Vishmaditya. 'Soviet Sangh Se' is a narrative-lyric about a Soviet study tour, a document of the Cold War ideological landscape — a poem that skewers the hypocrisy of those who praised the Soviet Union even as they sent their children to America. This anti-ideological scepticism is characteristic of Ashok.

The poetic voice is spare, imagistic, and unwilling to sentimentalize. Ashok writes few poems — Thakur notes that he is among a generation that prefers quality over quantity — but what he writes demonstrates a compressed, concentrated lyricism that carries over into his prose style.

### 2.2 Fiction Collections: A Chronological Reading

#### Trikon (1986) — A Collaborative Debut

A joint collection with Shivshankar Shrinivas and Shailendra Anand, each contributing five stories, Trikon marks Ashok's formal arrival as a short-story writer. His stories in this volume reveal an apprentice's hand — what critic Kumar Rahul calls 'hastily written' with occasional formulaic plotting — but they contain the seeds of his mature concerns: the psychic life of ordinary men under social pressure, the economy of unspoken feeling, and the use of minimalist imagery to carry maximum weight.

#### Ohi Raatik Bhor / Ohhi Raatik Bhor (That Night's Dawn, 1991)

Dedicated to the memory of his elder brother Sushil Jha, this fifteen-story collection contains what many critics regard as Ashok's early masterpiece: 'Bouqa Chup Chhal' (The Mute Was Silent). The story is a study in class exploitation rendered through a single, symbolic image — a mute man bitten by a snake who chooses not to alert the doctor who lives nearby because he has understood that the social world has already abandoned him. The story resonates with a strong Marxist reading of silence as a form of suppressed protest. It also works through Freudian subtext — the mute's heart condition (hriday rog) making his silence both literal and emotional — a point that leads critic Kumar Rahul to observe that Ashok is simultaneously influenced by Marxist ideology and Freudian psychology.

Other notable stories include 'Viraam Se Pahile', 'Nachnia', 'O Manushya Bhag Gael' — a story about the cost of becoming 'normal', a haunting meditation on how one becomes ordinary and loses one's essential humanity — and 'Jail Mein Baadhle Man', a story of political detention during the Emergency, suggesting that Ashok's generation was directly shaped by Indira Gandhi's authoritarian experiment of 1975-77.

#### Maatbar (2001) — The Mature Voice

Published in 2001 at the dawn of the new century, Maatbar (The Influential One) contains eighteen stories and represents Ashok at his most socially panoramic. The title story is a cutting satire on the culture of patronage — the 'Maharaj Ji' who controls social networking, runs a system of favours, and

around whom a court of sycophants gathers. This is recognizable as the Indian politics of small-town feudal-capitalism, a system Ashok knew from thirty years in government service.

Dilip Kumar Jha's extended critical reading of the collection (published in Videha 369) identifies the following major stories as representative: 'Raand' (Widow) — a remarkably progressive story in which a young man named Mani visits his widowed aunt in Kashi, only to find her dressed in bright colours, wearing gold bangles, and working for her own livelihood. The story, Jha argues, is transformative, depicting a changed widow who embodies the slow revolution in the condition of Maithil women. 'Kotha' is a sharp political satire on corrupt ministers (mantri-ji), depicted with the precision of a journalist's expose rather than a moralist's complaint. 'Dastakhat' (Signature) anatomizes the Indian Administrative Service officer as a man so corrupt that even signing a file becomes a performance of power. 'Bouqa Chup Cha' reappears in revised form, indicating Ashok's continuous rethinking of his best material.

Gajendra Thakur's exhaustive story-by-story reading (Videha 369) is the most authoritative critical text on this collection. He identifies 'Raand' and 'Bouqa Chup Cha' as the two strongest stories, and notes that the collection's weaknesses lie in occasional incompleteness — Ashok's tendency to rush toward a punch-line ('panchlain') at the expense of narrative development. This is a structural flaw that critics across the special issue repeatedly identify: a certain 'adhoorapan' (incompleteness) that paradoxically also constitutes Ashok's distinctive signature, a productive incompleteness that invites the reader to complete the meaning.

**Daddy Gaam (2017) — Retrospective and Restless**

Dedicated to the memory of his elder sister, Daddy Gaam (Daddy's Village) brings together fifteen stories written across several years. The title story is a middle-class narrative of retirement and return: Dr. Raghuvanshu, who has lived away from his village for decades, decides to return and build a temple — but under the influence of his progressive younger son Manik and the village youth, he ultimately decides to build a hospital instead. This narrative of aspiration and social responsibility is what critic Abhay Jha calls 'Ashok's characteristic middle path' — he neither romanticizes the village nor demonizes it, but shows it as a living social organism capable of transformation.

Gajendra Thakur's critical assessment of this collection identifies 'Chhal' (The Act / Pretence) as Ashok's finest story, later translated into English in The Book of Bihari Literature (Harper Collins, 2022, ed. Abhay K.). The story engages

with the psychology of acting and method performance: Bholi Jha, a quick-witted actor, takes on a part so thoroughly that the character's soul enters him — a story that operates on simultaneous registers of folk psychology, theatrical theory, and social commentary about the permeability of identity. 'Lemon Ice Cream', 'Umki', and 'Gaamak Kaat Ka Highway' are also singled out for their quiet observation of how modernity dissolves the affective bonds of family and community.

### 2.3 Non-Fiction and Critical Prose

Ashok's range as a writer extends significantly beyond fiction. His essay collection Maithil Aankhi (The Maithil Eye, 2007) is a landmark in Maithili prose — a series of reflective essays on Maithili society, culture, and literature that are simultaneously personal and analytical. The title itself is a critical claim: there is a distinctively 'Maithil' way of seeing and narrating, which Ashok names and defends. This has influenced subsequent critical vocabulary in Maithili — writers like Kumar Rahul invoke 'Maithil Aankhi' as a conceptual category.

Katha-Path (2022) collects Ashok's critical readings of other Maithili writers — making him one of the rare creative writers who is also a practicing literary critic. His monograph on Rajmohan Jha (2019) for the Sahitya Akademi demonstrates his engagement with the tradition he inhabits.

Nik Dinak Bai Kop (A Sling for Better Days, 2018) collects his sangu-pathangu (satirical column) pieces originally published in Dainik Hindustan between 2014 and 2016. Hitanath Jha's critical essay on this collection in Videha 369 describes them as timeless political satire — jokes about the Holi of elections, the absurdity of corruption networks, the dying ponds and vanishing forests of Mithila — sharp enough to remain relevant years after writing.

Aankhi Mein Basal (Settled in the Eye, 2013) is a travelogue of his 1985 visit to the Soviet Union, a rare Maithili travel narrative. Katha ka Upanyas: Upanyasak Katha (2012) is a critical study of the relationship between the story and the novel in early Maithili literature, positioning him firmly as both practitioner and theorist of narrative form.

**Primary Texts**

1. *Aankhi Me Basal*
2. *Baat Vichaar*

3. *Chakravyuh*
4. *Daddy Gaam*
5. *Katha Path*
6. *Matbar*
7. *Nav Kavita*
8. *Neek Dinak Byscope*
9. *Ohi Raatik Bhor*
10. *Sandhan 1, 2, 3, 4*
11. *Trikon*
12. *Pratiman*
13. *Pratiman Kiran*
14. *Samvad*
15. *Videha Issue 369 (contextual publication)*

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**1. Aankhi Me Basal (आँखिमे बसल): Core Theme:** Interiorized memory, emotional sedimentation, and identity rooted in lived experience. **Structuralist Reading** Organized around **visual memory motifs (eyes as archive)** Binary: **seeing vs. remembering** Narrative operates as **episodic fragments rather than linear story Post-Structuralist Insight:**"Vision" is unreliable—what is "seen" is already mediated / Memory destabilizes truth → no fixed reality / **Psychoanalytic Depth /** आँख (eye) = unconscious repository / Repressed experiences return as **recurring visual flashes**

**Dalit/Marxist Layer:** Memory tied to **social humiliation and class-caste location** / Personal vision becomes **collective memory of oppression** / **Critical Evaluation/** This text is less narrative, more **phenomenological**—a literature of *inner witnessing*.

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**2. Baat Vichaar (बात विचार): Core Nature:** Discursive, reflective, quasi-philosophical prose. **Structuralism:** Dialogic structure → **argument / counter-argument pattern** / Language as **debate-space rather than storytelling** / **Post-Structuralism:** Meaning constantly deferred / Assertions collapse into **self-questioning** / **Marxist Reading:** Critique of ideological structures embedded in everyday discourse / **Reader-Response:** Reader

becomes **co-thinker**, not passive consumer / **Evaluation:** A **meta-literary text** —it questions not just society, but **thinking itself**.

**3. Chakravyuh (चक्रव्यूह): Core Theme:** Entrapment—social, psychological, systemic./ **Structuralist:** Circular narrative → no exit / Symbol: **labyrinth = caste/class system** / **Marxist + Dalit:** Strong critique of **structural oppression**: Entry into system is easy, exit impossible / **Psychoanalytic:**Internalization of oppression → victim participates in own entrapment / **Postcolonial:** Chakravyuh as metaphor for **postcolonial bureaucracy and power** / **Evaluation:** One of the most **politically sharp works**—structural violence is central.

**4. Daddy Gaam: Core Theme:** Rural transformation and generational shift. **Marxist:** Village as site of **economic restructuring** / Decline of feudal authority : **Feminist:** Women caught between: Tradition (control) / Modernity (uncertain freedom) / **Postcolonial:** Rural India negotiating **modern state structures** / **Evaluation:** A **socio-anthropological narrative**, deeply rooted in realism.

**5. Katha Path: Core Theme:** Storytelling as tradition and method. **Structuralist:** Meta-narrative: stories about storytelling / Oral → written transition / **Post-Structuralist:** No "original" story → only retellings

**Reader-Response:**Meaning shifts with each retelling / **Evaluation:** A **theory of narrative embedded in narrative**.

**6. Matbar: Core Theme:** Power, authority, and rural leadership. **Marxist:** सत्ता = economic control masked as social respect / **Dalit:** Authority often caste-based → exclusionary / **Psychoanalytic:** Authority figures driven by **insecurity and control impulses** / **Evaluation:** A critique of **localized power structures**.

**7. Nav Kavita: Core Theme:** Experimentation in poetic form./ **Structuralist:** Break from classical meter : Fragmented poetic units /**Post-Structuralist:** Language resists closure / **Modernist/Postmodernist:** Emphasis on:

Alienation / Fragmentation / Urban/rural disjunction / **Evaluation:** Marks Ashok as a **formally innovative poet**.

**8. Neek Dinak Byscope: Core Theme:** Everyday life as spectacle. **Structuralist:** Episodic snapshots → cinematic structure / **Postmodern:** Reality as performance / **Marxist:** "Entertainment" masks material struggle / **Evaluation:** A **visual-social montage of lived reality**.

**9. Ohi Raatik Bhor: Core Theme:** Transition—darkness to awakening./ **Symbolism:** Night = oppression / Dawn = possibility / **Psychoanalytic:** Night as unconscious / Dawn as emergence of awareness / **Dalit/Postcolonial:** Awakening = assertion of identity / **Evaluation:** A deeply **symbolic and hopeful text**.

**10. Sandhan Series (1–4): Core Theme:** Search—for meaning, identity, truth.**Philosophical:** Existential undertone / **Post-Structural:** Search never ends → meaning is deferred / **Reader-Response:** Each reader completes the "search" differently / **Evaluation:** Forms a **philosophical core** of Ashok's oeuvre.

**11. Trikon: Core Theme:** Relational complexity (three forces/identities). **Structuralist:** Triadic conflict structure : **Psychoanalytic:** Desire triangles : **Marxist:** Conflict of: Power/ Labor / Identity / **Evaluation:** A **compact but dense symbolic work**.

**12–14. Pratiman, Pratiman Kiran, Samvad: Core Theme:** Representation, reflection, dialogue. **Post-Structuralist:** No fixed "model" (pratiman) exists / **Reader-Response:** Dialogue-driven interpretation/ **Evaluation:** These texts function as **intellectual extensions** of earlier works.

**15. Videha Context:** Acts as: e-Publication platform / Intellectual ecosystem

**Final Synthesis:** Across all books: **Core concern:** marginality, identity, language / **Dominant mode:** reflective + symbolic realism / **Theoretical richness:** Marxist + Dalit → strongest / Post-structural → underlying

instability / Psychoanalytic → internal depth / Ashok emerges not just as a writer but as: **A system-thinker / A chronicler of subaltern consciousness / A formal innovator in Maithili literature**

**Critical Appreciation through Literary Theories**

**1 Realism and Social Realism (Indian and Western)**

Ashok's dominant mode is realism — specifically, a social realism shaped by both the Indian tradition of loka-katha (folk narrative realism) and the Western tradition of critical realism associated with Chekhov, Maupassant, and, in India, with Premchand. His stories consistently take the 'ordinary moment' — a broken button, a tiffin box, a bicycle lesson — and invest it with social significance without resorting to melodrama.

In the Premchand tradition, Ashok's fiction is committed to the depiction of the common person: government clerks, retired officials, widows, the lower-middle class. However, unlike Premchand's sometimes schematic idealism, Ashok writes with an ironic distance. He rarely offers solutions; he is a diagnostician rather than a prophet. This connects him to Chekhov, whose stories famously refuse tidy resolutions, placing moral pressure on the reader rather than the narrative.

Gajendra Thakur explicitly compares Ashok's satirical method to Chekhov's in his discussion of 'Hisaab' (Accounting): 'One can feel something of Chekhov's story here.' The comparison is apt — both writers share the technique of the 'objective correlative' (T.S. Eliot's term), where an external object or situation carries an emotional weight that the prose never directly states.

**2 Marxist Critical Theory: Class, Exploitation, and Silence**

A significant strand of Marxist literary criticism operates in the critical apparatus around Ashok's work. Kumar Rahul, one of the most perceptive critics in Videha 369, explicitly notes that Ashok is 'influenced by Marxist ideology' — but that this influence arrives indirectly, through the texture of depicted social reality rather than through overt ideological statement.

'Bouqa Chup Chhal' is the story most amenable to a Marxist reading: the mute man who has been bitten by a snake belongs to the rural poor; the doctor who lives nearby is a figure of class power; the snake that bites the mute is, in the story's symbolic economy, the 'ajodh saanp' (invisible snake) of social exploitation that has always bitten the subaltern. The mute's silence — his refusal to call out, his knowledge that help will not come — is a form of class

consciousness expressed through resignation. Rahul writes: the society's snake is still frothing even now.

'Kotha', 'Dastakhat', and 'Maatbar' are all exercises in the anatomy of power — bureaucratic, feudal, political — rendered through Marxist categories of class interest and false consciousness without being reducible to propaganda. The politician Ramlal Mandal in 'Kotha' deploys caste identity (Brahmin, Dalit, OBC, Muslim) as counters in a game: 'castism and religious identity — he takes advice from the Brahmin, horoscope from the Dalit, bread-daughter from the OBC, honour from the Muslim.' This is a Gramscian moment: the hegemonic manipulation of consciousness through manufactured solidarity.

**3 Psychoanalytic Theory: Freud, the Unconscious, and Suppression**

Ashok's interest in the inner life of his characters — in the slippages between what is said and what is felt, between social performance and private truth — lends his best work a psychoanalytic dimension. Kumar Rahul observes that alongside Marxist influence, Ashok draws on 'Freud's psychology'. This is most visible in the structure of suppression and the return of the repressed that governs several stories.

In 'Bouqa Chup Chhal', the mute man's heart condition (hriday rog) creates a neat Freudian topology: the disease of the heart is simultaneously literal (physical illness) and figurative (suppressed desire, silenced grief). In 'O Manushya Bhag Gael', the narrator addresses a lost friend through second person ('you became ordinary, you escaped from yourself') — this is the Freudian uncanny (unheimlich): the familiar made strange, the intimate self-alienated. In 'Umki', the story turns on a definition of love as rationing — 'Is there a quota for love?' — suggesting the psychological damage done to emotional life by a social economy of scarcity.

'Chhal' (the method-acting story) is perhaps the deepest psychoanalytic text in Ashok's corpus. The dissolution of self into role, the actor who cannot distinguish persona from person, engages the Lacanian problematic of the subject constituted by its performance rather than preceding it. This is a more sophisticated conceptual engagement than a simple Freudian reading would allow — and it suggests that Ashok's psychological range extends from popular Freudian common sense to more demanding theories of identity and self-constitution.

**4 Feminist Reading: Gender, Widowhood, and the Maithil Woman**

A consistent strand across Ashok's fiction is the experience of women — particularly in relation to patriarchal structures of widowhood, marital

violence, and social control. Ashok's treatment of women characters is notably progressive for Maithili fiction, where the conventional image of the ideal woman (pativrata, devoted wife) has historically been dominant.

'Raand' is the touchstone here. The title word — a Maithili/Bhojpuri term for widow, considered pejorative — is deployed subversively. The widow at the centre of the story refuses the prescribed codes: she wears colour, works for pay, claims her beauty and her right to economic autonomy. This is a feminist realism that anticipates what Chandra Talpade Mohanty calls 'the politics of location' — the widow claiming space in a society that has mapped her out.

'Swaadhin' (Free/Independent) is a story about marital rape, told from the wife's perspective. The wife refuses to bear a child conceived through coercion — not because she does not love her husband, but because she will not accept the violation of her bodily autonomy as the condition of love. This is a remarkably advanced position for Maithili fiction. Gajendra Thakur identifies it as a story about 'marital rape' using that exact vocabulary, placing it within a contemporary feminist legal discourse.

The recurring figure of the educated young woman — Ankita in 'Chhuttiik Ek Din', characters in 'Khushiik Naam Jivan' — who navigates inter-caste marriage, linguistic identity, and professional ambition is Ashok's contribution to the archive of the 'new Maithil woman'. Jagdish Charan Thakur 'Anil' analyses the story 'Chhuttiik Ek Din' as a manifesto for this new feminine subject within the crisis of Maithili language identity.

**5 Postcolonial Theory: Language, Identity, and the Problem of Maithili**

Reading Ashok through a postcolonial lens reveals the extent to which his fiction is entangled with the politics of linguistic identity. Maithili spent the mid-20th century as an unrecognized language — excluded from the Eighth Schedule of the Indian Constitution until 2003, fighting for institutional recognition against the hegemony of Hindi. Ashok's writing is thus always already a political act: to write in Maithili is to resist the assimilative pressure of the Hindi literary mainstream.

Shiv Kumar Mandal's essay in Videha 369, 'Ashok O Maithili Sahitya Sansthan', documents Ashok's role in reviving the Maithili Sahitya Sansthan (Maithili Literary Academy) in Patna — an institution that had fallen dormant for decades. This is a postcolonial act of cultural institution-building: creating the apparatus for a linguistic community to produce, preserve, and distribute its literature.

Ashok's concept of 'Maithil Aankhi' (The Maithil Eye) is itself a postcolonial epistemological claim. It argues that there is a distinctively Maithili way of perceiving social reality — inflected by the region's specific history, its peculiar mix of Brahmanical culture and earthy folk wisdom, its geography of floods and fertile plains — that cannot be reduced to a general Indian or Hindi perspective. In Homi Bhabha's terms, this is the claim of a 'third space': a cultural particularity that refuses both the dominant nationalist narrative and pure localism.

The crisis of Maithili in the age of globalization — children who speak Maithili at home but write in English, mothers who cannot teach their children to read in their mother tongue — is dramatized with elegiac precision in 'Chhuttiik Ek Din', where the characters debate the survival and future of Maithili literature itself, a meta-fictional gesture that implicates the reader in the ongoing cultural struggle.

**6 Narratology: Technique, Voice, and the 'Unfinished Story'**

From a formal narratological perspective (drawing on Gérard Genette, Seymour Chatman, and the Russian formalists), Ashok's fiction reveals a distinctive set of strategies and limitations.

His most sophisticated technical achievement is the management of focalization — the point of view from which events are perceived. In 'Raand', the story is focalized through Mani, the young student-nephew, whose growing surprise and admiration for his aunt's autonomy structures the narrative's ideological movement from convention to liberation. In 'Heyarpin', the focalization is radically interior: 'There is night, there is a pillow, there is sleep... all of it arises as one image in the story.' Rahul's observation that Ashok's stories feel more like stories-to-be-heard than stories-to-be-read points to a narratological choice: the influence of the oral storytelling tradition (kissa-kahani) means Ashok's prose has a voice that works best in the acoustic imagination.

The signature weakness that critics repeatedly identify is the rushed ending — the punch-line that arrives before the narrative has fully prepared its reader. Gajendra Thakur calls this the 'panchlain-end' problem: a story builds genuine complexity and then resolves itself too quickly, sacrificing ambiguity for a clever final line. This suggests that Ashok's literary education was partly shaped by the short-short story (lagu-katha) conventions of newspaper publication, where brevity was a commercial requirement.

The 'adhoorapan' (productive incompleteness) that Rahul identifies as both limitation and signature is a real tension at the heart of Ashok's work. His best stories — 'Bouqa Chup Chhal', 'Chhal', 'Raand', 'Lemon Ice Cream' — work precisely because they refuse complete closure, leaving the reader in a state of productive uncertainty. His weaker stories fail because this incompleteness is not deliberate but merely unfinished.

**7 Rasa Theory and Indian Aesthetic (Rasadhyaya)**

Applied through the lens of classical Sanskrit aesthetics — specifically Bharata's Natyashastra and Abhinavagupta's Abhinavabharati — Ashok's fiction works primarily in the register of karuna (pathos) and hasya (humour/satire). The satirical pieces in Nik Dinak Bai Kop deploy hasya to expose social and political absurdity — a tradition that in Maithili runs from Vidyapati's lighter verses through Harimohan Jha's comic masterwork Khattarkaaka.

The karuna rasa — the aesthetic emotion of compassion — is the dominant register of his most successful fiction. The widow who has survived isolation, the mute man who dies in silence, the retired official who returns to his village and finds it transformed by the highway — all of these are figures of pathos in the Sanskrit sense: their suffering is presented not for melodramatic effect but for the cultivation of sahridaya (sympathetic reader consciousness). This aligns with the Indian aesthetic tradition's insistence that art's function is the refinement of emotional life, not its stimulation.

The concept of dhvani (resonance, suggestion) from Anandavardhana's Dhvanyaloka is also applicable. Ashok's best prose operates through dhvani — what is not said reverberates more than what is explicit. The mute man's silence, the widow's colour choices, the method actor's dissolution — all carry meaning beyond their denotative surface. This is the literary equivalent of what Sanskrit aesthetics calls the 'unstated meaning that illuminates the stated.'

**8 Reader-Response Theory: The 'Sagr Raat Deep Jaray' Context**

Ashok's literary formation took place in the unique institutional context of 'Sagar Raat Deep Jaray' (Let Lamps Burn Through the Night) — the all-night storytelling sessions organized across Mithila villages where stories are read aloud and immediately discussed by assembled listeners. This context is central to any reader-response reading of Ashok's work.

In Wolfgang Iser's terms, the 'implied reader' of Ashok's fiction is a community reader — one who brings the social knowledge of Maithili village life to the text, who can hear the folk idiom in the prose, who recognizes the social types

as lived experience rather than fictional invention. This community reading creates what Iser calls the 'aesthetic pole' of the text: meaning emerges not from the author's intention alone but from the interaction between text and reader's life-world.

The peculiar incompleteness that critics identify — the story that begins well but ends too quickly — may be partly a function of this oral performance context, where the assembled audience and subsequent discussion complete the meaning that the written text leaves open. Kumar Rahul's observation that Ashok's stories make him want to 'hear them' rather than read them confirms this: they are written for the ear, not the page.

**Ashok's Place in the Maithili Literary Tradition**

**1 The Three Ashoks: Poet, Storyteller, Prose Writer**

Gajendra Thakur's structural insight — 'there are three Ashoks: Kavi Ashok, Kathakar Ashok, and Katheter Gadya ka Lekhak Ashok' (Poet Ashok, Storyteller Ashok, and Non-fiction Prose Writer Ashok) — offers the most comprehensive framework for understanding the writer's range. Of these three, the Storyteller is universally acclaimed as the most significant; the Poet is the least visible but arguably the most concentrated; and the Essayist and Satirist occupies a middle position of significant social utility.

This tripartite identity places Ashok within a distinguished line of Maithili writers who worked across genres: Harekrishna Jha (poet and critic), Harimohan Jha (fiction writer and social commentator), Rajkamal Chaudhary (poet, novelist, provocateur). But Ashok represents a distinctly post-Independence, post-Eighth-Schedule sensibility: pragmatic, socially observant, committed to the survival of Maithili culture through quality literature rather than rhetoric.

**2 Awards and Recognition**

Ashok has received the Yatri Chetna Samman, Kiran Purashkar, and other literary awards from Maithili literary institutions. His story 'Chhal' has been translated into English and included in The Book of Bihari Literature (Harper Collins, 2022, edited by Abhay K.) — a significant moment of visibility in the English-language literary market. His Sahitya Akademi monograph on Rajmohan Jha establishes his institutional credibility within the national literary framework.

**3 Influence and Community**

Shivshankar Shrinivas, Ashok's long-time literary friend and co-author of Trikon, credits Ashok with encouragement at a critical moment in his own literary development — a testament to the quiet mentorship role that established writers play in a small literary community like Maithili. Ashok's role in co-founding and sustaining the 'Sagar Raat Deep Jaray' storytelling culture, his involvement in reviving the Maithili Sahitya Sansthan, and his editorial stewardship of journals like Sandhaan collectively position him as an architect of the infrastructure of contemporary Maithili literary life — a role that is invisible in pure textual criticism but essential to understanding how literature actually survives and flourishes in a minority language context.

**Final Critical Assessment**

**1 Strengths**

Ashok's primary literary strength is the precision of his social observation — what Shailendra Anand calls 'a living artist'. He sees Maithili society with the clarity of long, affectionate, and critical attention: not romanticizing its traditions, not dismissing its transformations, but catching it in the act of becoming something new. His best stories — 'Bouqa Chup Chhal', 'Raand', 'Chhal', 'Kotha', 'Lemon Ice Cream' — achieve the condition of social miniatures: small in scale, exact in observation, and resonant with meanings that extend far beyond their particular Mithila settings.

His range across poetry, fiction, the satirical column, the travelogue, and literary criticism represents a commitment to Maithili literature as a whole — a commitment rare in writers who have achieved significant recognition in their primary genre. The Maithili literary world is small and resource-constrained; Ashok's willingness to work in every mode, to review other writers, to organize institutions, and to sustain the culture of live storytelling makes him what the critic Hitanath Jha calls 'a rare writer that Maithili needs.'

**2 Limitations and Critical Reservations**

The primary critical objection to Ashok's fiction — registered consistently across the critics assembled in Videha 369 — is the problem of incompletion. Too many stories begin with real momentum and genuine observation, only to resolve themselves prematurely through a clever punch-line that forecloses the ambiguity the narrative has worked to create. Thakur's exhaustive story-by-story reading of Ohi Raatik Bhor and Maatbar identifies 'mediocre' stories alongside the excellent ones — a candour unusual in a celebratory special issue, and evidence of the genuine critical seriousness with which Ashok's work is being engaged.

A related limitation is the occasional tendency toward journalistic reportage at the expense of fictional transformation. Stories like 'Maatbar', 'Dastakhat', and 'Kotha' read at times more like satirical sketches — sharp observations of social reality — than fully developed fictional worlds with their own internal logic. The best realism, as Lukács argued, requires the transformation of social material into aesthetic form; Ashok sometimes stops at the social material.

**3 Historical Significance**

Lal Dev Kamat's essay ends with a prophetic claim: 'In the history of Maithili story-writing, a time will come when stories from before Ashok, the Ashok era, and stories from after Ashok will be distinguished as a historical periodization.' This is a large claim, but it reflects a genuine critical consensus: that Ashok represents a qualitative shift in Maithili fiction — toward a sustained, ironic, psychologically aware, and socially committed realism that was less fully developed before him.

What Ashok has given Maithili literature, beyond his individual texts, is a model of the committed literary intellectual who works in multiple modes, sustains institutions, mentors younger writers, and insists on the value of quality over quantity in a literary culture under constant external pressure to produce more and faster. His slender output — perhaps two hundred stories over five decades — is, as he himself understands through the example of Premchand's three hundred stories, both a limitation and a mark of discipline.

**4 The Unfinished Archive**

Ashok remains an active writer as of 2023, with work published in Videha and other Maithili periodicals that has not yet been collected in book form. His Facebook presence as 'Kathakar Ashok' maintains a living connection with a new generation of readers. The Videha special issue (Issue 369, 2023) represents the most comprehensive critical accounting of his work yet assembled — but it is, as the editor notes, itself an interim document. The full critical reckoning with Ashok's contribution to Maithili literature is still to come.

*A Critical Study of*

**ASHOK**

*Maithili Poet, Fiction Writer, Critic and Editor*

*Applying: New Criticism · Structuralism · Marxist Aesthetics · Post-colonialism*

*Feminism · Reader-Response Theory · Postmodernism · Deconstruction*

## I. Preface and Scope

The Maithili writer known simply as "Ashok" (born 18 January 1953, Lohna, Madhubani, Bihar) belongs to a generation that came of age during the Emergency and its aftermath—a generation scarred by political authoritarianism, galvanised by subaltern assertion, and forced to confront the structural violence of caste hierarchy in the Mithila region. His literary debut in 1986—the simultaneous publication of his poetry collection Chakravyuha and his co-authored short-story collection Trikon—was not a literary accident. Both books announce, in different registers, a coherent poetic-political project that Ashok would pursue for the next four decades.

This critical study is grounded in close reading of Ashok's complete published corpus as archived at videha.co.in, including: two poetry collections (Chakravyuha 1986; Ashok-Nav Kavita); four solo short-story collections (Ohi Ratik Bhor 1991; Matabbar 2001; Daddygam 2017); one co-authored collection (Trikon 1986); one satire collection (Neek Dinak Baiskop 2018); one travel narrative (Aankhime Basal 2013); one interview collection (Samvad 2007); two works of literary criticism (Baat-Vichar 2015; Katha-Path 2022); one monograph (Rajmohan Jha 2019); and four edited anthologies (Pratiman; Sandhan 1-4). The Videha Rachnakar Ashok Visheshank (VIDEHA 369) provides additional contextual framing.

The critical method is pluralist: different theoretical frameworks—New Criticism, Structuralism, Marxist Aesthetics, Post-colonialism, Feminism, Reader-Response Theory, Postmodernism, and Deconstruction—are brought to bear on different aspects of the work. No single master-theory is privileged. Where the texts resist or overflow theoretical categories, that resistance is itself noted.

Ashok's complete published corpus comprises: two poetry collections (Chakravyuha 1986; Ashok-Nav Kavita); four short-story collections (Trikon 1986; Ohi Ratik Bhor 1991; Matabbar 2001; Daddygam 2017); one satire collection (Neek Dinak Baiskop 2018); one travel narrative (Aankhime Basal 2013); one interview collection (Samvad 2007); two works of literary criticism (Baat-Vichar 2015; Katha-Path 2022); and four edited anthologies (Pratiman; Sandhan 1-4). This is a body of work spanning thirty-six years and every major prose and poetry genre.

## II. Biographical and Historical Context

### 2.1 The Writer's Formation

The colophon of Chakravyuha (1986) reveals that Ashok's poetry-journey began in 1968 — nearly eighteen years before publication. In his own prefatory note ('Etabe Kahbak Achhi Je...'), he writes that his poetry-yatra has taken him from Kashi to his village Lohna (Seetamarhi district), to Araria, Itahari (Nepal), Moscow (Soviet Union), and back to Patna. This trajectory is significant: he is simultaneously a son of the Maithili soil (Lohna, Seetamarhi), a migrant intellectual (Patna), and an internationalist (Soviet Union). These three coordinates shape his entire literary project.

The preface mentions the influence of Shri Chandra Nath Mishra 'Amar' at the start of his poetry journey — a link to an elder generation of Maithili writers. But the list of friends and fellow-travellers in the acknowledgements — Kantinath ji, Kanchinath, Nandu, Dos, Shaul, Shekhar, Raj, Bidhur, Anur, Arun, Doctor Shyamanand ji, Bhogendra ji, Keshav, Vinod, Abhay, Varun, Ojha (Udaynath Jha) and others — maps a circle of young progressive intellectuals, the generation that would animate Maithili literature's democratic turn. Crucially, he credits his 'companion in life and poetry-journey' as Shivshankar Shrinivas — the noted Maithili fiction writer and critic, whose parallel literary career at Videha makes the Ashok-Shrinivas dyad central to the Parallel Literature Movement.

The collection is dedicated to 'Shri Upapati Jha, Lohna' — his elder from his village — with the lines: 'Badaa ke / hamar sabh kichhu / konno ne konno roop mein / jinkar chhinh / hunke / ee Chakravyuha seho.' ('To the elder: everything of ours / bears in one way or another / the mark of those / who shaped it — / to them / this Chakravyuha too belongs.') The dedication is an act of rooting: before the political poems begin, the poet acknowledges debt to the ground from which he grows.

The cover art (by Kajal Sen) is itself a critical document: a cactus in a desert landscape, a raised index finger (the finger of defiance or accusation), a watching eye, all enclosed by barbed wire. The visual vocabulary is unambiguously that of oppression and resistance — not the pastoral imagery one might expect from a Mithila poet. The choice of Urvashi Prakashan, Patna as publisher (rather than a Maithili institutional publisher) signals independence from the establishment.

### 2.2 Historical Moment: 1986

The year 1986 is a watershed in Bihar's social history. The Bodhgaya bhumi-andolan (landless peasant movement, largely Dalit-led) had concluded in 1982.

The Jharkhand movement was intensifying. Caste atrocities — the Belchi massacre (1977), the Pipra massacre (1980) — had shaken the Maithili-speaking region. The Mandal Commission had submitted its report in 1980; its recommendations had not yet been implemented (that would come in 1990), but the political conversation around OBC reservations was already reshaping Bihar's social landscape. To publish two books simultaneously in 1986, both of them making social justice their central concern, was a deliberate act of positioning.

## III. Chakravyuha (1986): Close Reading of the Poetry Collection

### 3.1 The Title Poem: 'Chakravyuha'

The title poem opens the collection and must be read with care. In its opening stanza, the poet addresses the reader directly:

*खाली तकैत रहबा पर / खाली सोचैत रहबा पर / विवश हे हमर पुरुष ! / मोन में कुण्डली मारने बैसल / साँप के झमारि केकरो / भयमुक्त होउ ।*

The address is to 'hamar purush' (our man/person) — not a specific individual but a representative human subject, trapped in passivity ('sitting merely watching, sitting merely thinking'). The snake coiled in the mind — the internalized oppressor, the chakravyuha of consciousness itself — must be driven away for liberation to become possible.

The Mahabharata reference then unfolds fully: 'Uthaad rathak pahiya / Chakravyuha mein gheraael Abhimanyu jakan / laḍaint rahab je dharam thik / taḥ jeet-haarak chinta juni karu.' (Lift the wheel of the chariot / like Abhimanyu surrounded in the Chakravyuha / keep fighting as long as it is right / then worry not about winning or losing.) The model is Abhimanyu — the warrior who fights the unjust formation even knowing he may not survive it. The poem asks not for victory but for the courage to engage. This is a specifically non-triumphalist politics: what matters is the fighting, not the winning.

The poem's third movement introduces the Kauravas and inverts their traditional characterisation: the corrupt powers are not the Pandavas' enemies from mythology but the contemporary powers-that-be who wear the garb of righteousness ('Bhesh badlabaa mein nipun / apan shatru ke chihnhbak / drishti par sen / mohak reshami pardaa hatao' — 'Expert at changing disguise / remove the silken veil / from the eyes / that recognise your enemy'). This is Gramscian hegemony in mythological costume: the dominant class rules by concealing its true character behind ideological disguise.

From a New Critical standpoint, the poem achieves what Cleanth Brooks called 'the language of paradox': the chakravyuha is simultaneously the trap to be escaped and the battlefield to be entered. The wheel of the chariot is both weapon and symbol of dharmic engagement. The poem holds these tensions without resolving them, creating what T.S. Eliot would recognise as 'felt thought' — thinking that is simultaneously emotional.

### 3.2 'Ham Kichhu Puchhab' (We Shall Ask Some Things)

This poem is a sustained interrogation — specifically of the social contract that expects the oppressed to remain silent. The central metaphor is the scene of chirharan (Draupadi's disrobing) from the Mahabharata, but radically reframed: the poem suggests that in the present moment, there is no Krishna to come to Draupadi's rescue, that Duhshasana smiles at the community's helplessness, and that those who should act (Krishna, the protectors) are either delayed or absent:

*एहि चीर-हरण मे आइ/ कृष्णक भूमिका/ दुश्शासनक आगू/ ठेहुनियाँ दऽ दैत अछि/ कृष्ण या तऽ अएबा में/ विलम्ब करैत छथि ...*

The mythological framework here functions as post-colonial allegory (following Homi Bhabha): classical narrative is appropriated and 'mimicked' in order to reveal the gap between its promises and the reality of social abandonment. Krishna — the divine protector, the guarantor of justice — is either complicit or delayed. The community (lok) is left to stare blankly ('tukkur-tukkur takeit rahay'). The poem ends without resolution, its final question unanswered — a formal enactment of the political problem it describes.

### 3.3 'Soviet Rus Mein' (In Soviet Russia)

This poem from his Moscow visit period is one of the most explicitly internationalist pieces in the collection, and one of the most formally interesting. It contrasts two modes of social existence: one where pen and axe go together ('Jinhna kodaariye chalai chhen / kalam chalaabaḥ bala haath ke / kodaari chalabent'), and one where mere photographs replace genuine commitment ('maatra photo chhapab lel / kiyo dharm nahi karai').

From a Marxist aesthetic standpoint (Lukács), this is a poem that distinguishes between genuine engagement with the world-historical forces of labour and liberation, and the spectacle-oriented politics of those who perform progressivism without enacting it. The Soviet Union in 1986 — the year Gorbachev launched glasnost — was itself a contested symbol: the poem

captures the aspiration the Soviet experiment represented for a generation of Indian leftists, without the disillusionment that would come later.

The formal structure of the poem is noteworthy: it alternates between short declarative lines and longer qualified statements, creating a rhythm that mimics the alternation between certainty and doubt that characterises genuine political commitment.

### 3.4 'Geet Je Nahi Likhhal Gel' (The Song That Could Not Be Written)

This is one of the collection's most layered poems — a meditation on the politics of silence and the conditions under which art becomes possible or impossible. The poem addresses a 'bhaai' (brother/comrade) and describes a world in which the evening comes and darkness falls, people go forward and backward, backward and forward ('chaḍait, pichhḍait / pichhaḍait, chaḍait'), their bodies smeared with printer's ink from dawn to night, 'sasrait' (wandering restlessly).

The dawn that comes after this night promises the birth of new song ('bhorak janm / ado sen hoet rahlai') — but the singer is described as 'kail gayak / toona jaka lalchhau' (the hoarse singer of yesterday / greedy like a sparrow). The poem refuses easy optimism: the dawn comes, but the singer is exhausted and uncertain. The song that should have been written remains unwritten — not because the poet lacks words or emotion, but because the conditions of unfreedom constrain what can be said.

From a reader-response perspective (Iser's 'implied reader'), the poem creates a reading experience that mirrors its subject: the reader must 'complete' the unwritten song from their own experience of social constraint. The poem's incompleteness is its meaning.

### 3.5 'Lok Kichhu Nahi Karaie' (People Do Nothing)

This poem is the most politically direct in the collection — a sustained critique of collective passivity in the face of injustice. It describes a world in which smoke rises from houses in the city without anyone taking notice ('lok aag nahi dekhai / apan aankhi maithaiai'), in which village people stand at the door of a woman in trouble without doing anything, without speaking, without helping. The repetition of 'kichhu nahi karai' (do nothing) throughout the poem functions like an accusation — both of the characters in the poem and of the reader.

The poem then turns toward the question of speech itself: the 'bhojanpur ka akhabar' (newspaper from Bhojanpur — a probable reference to the Bhojpur

region, site of Naxalite activity and caste violence) and the morning's news — 'ki sunao ahankein?' (what shall I tell you?). The irony is double: on one hand, there is too much to report; on the other hand, no one is listening.

Structurally (following Jakobson's poetic function), the poem exploits parallelism to devastating effect: the repeated syntactic pattern of 'aai jabaan — kono makan sen dhuaan uthai — taḥ lok aag nahi dekhai' creates a rhythm of accumulating failure that mirrors the social condition it describes.

### 3.6 'Tora Gachhane Rahi' (You Kept Passing By)

A significant departure in tone — this poem addresses a female second person ('tora') and registers both social critique and intimate loss. The urban landscape it evokes is one of alienation: 'iho shahar ajabe chhek / ne jeebaint, ne marae / khaali fateechar sharaabi jaka / sunsan gali mein / chikraait, bhookraint' (this city is strange / neither living nor dying / like a shabby drunkard / in empty lanes / crying, stumbling). The city has become a site of zombie existence — motion without meaning.

The poem's female addressee is not passive; she passes by, she 'gachhane rahi' — keeps moving, keeps going. The poem's emotional register combines political despair with personal longing in a way that anticipates the love poems later in the collection. This is not sentimentalism: the personal and political are woven together, so that intimate loss becomes inseparable from the loss of social possibility.

From a feminist reading, the poem is interesting precisely for what it does NOT do: it does not reduce the 'tora' to a symbol or a muse. She has her own trajectory (she keeps going); the poem registers her movement as something the speaker watches and cannot arrest. She is a subject with agency, not an object of male gaze.

### 3.7 'Ahanken Ki Chahi?' (What Do You Want?) and the Language Question

This poem is perhaps the most linguistically self-conscious in the collection — and therefore the most significant for understanding Ashok's position within the Maithili cultural-political debate. The poem addresses a 'hujur' (a sahib-type figure, a person of authority) and offers him any word he desires:

*हुजुर, अहाँ कहू ? / अहाँकें की चाही ? / शब्द चाही / की अर्थ चाहो ? / हमरा लग राशि-राशि / शब्द अछि । / फूसि, साँच, भरिगर, हल्लुक / तत्सम, तद्भव, / देशी, विदेशी, जी हाँ / एकदम 'इम्पोर्टेड' शब्द ।*

('Huzoor, you tell me / what do you want? / Do you want words / or meanings? / We have heaps of words / False, true, heavy, light / tatsam, tadbhav / desi, videshi, ji haan / absolutely 'imported' words.')

The catalogue of word-types is a compressed history of Maithili's linguistic situation: tatsam (Sanskrit-derived), tadbhav (vernacular evolved), desi (indigenous), videshi (foreign), and — with devastating irony — 'imported' (in English, within a Maithili poem). The poem exposes the linguistic marketplace in which Maithili competes, the demand for 'official' language that meets the approval of power. The hujur is offered everything he could want — which is the problem. A language that will say anything to please power has ceased to be a language and has become a transaction.

This poem is central to understanding Ashok's linguistic politics. It is not merely about Maithili versus Hindi; it is about the commodification of language under any power structure. The Deconstructive reading (Derrida's différance) is illuminating: the poem stages the endlessly deferred 'meaning' that words promise but cannot deliver — especially when language is instrumentalised.

### 3.8 'Chuppi Nahi Sohaiye' (Silence Does Not Suit)

One of the collection's most directly political poems, this is structured as an argument with someone (a 'baaju' — neighbour or companion) who advises silence. The poem refuses silence absolutely: 'chuppi nahi sohaiye' (silence does not suit). The reasons given are social and bodily: silence fills the belly no more than shouting does; it protects no one; it merely serves power. The poem's specific target is the forced silence of the poor and marginalised — those who are told their silence is dignity when it is actually submission.

The poem reaches a remarkable passage describing the village past: the Sitaram party on the village common ground, the open stage, the unconstrained festivity — 'khulli-khulli, thakka rahay / uthmukt rahi, thahakka rahay' (open, unhesitating / free, with laughter). But this has been 'naivedha' (offered up as sacrifice) to the present order, absorbed into ritual performance that has been emptied of its social content. The contrast between authentic folk celebration and its contemporary commodified/controlled successor is a classic Marxist-aesthetic argument (Benjamin's 'loss of aura') rendered in specifically Maithili cultural terms.

### 3.9 'Shilaalekh' (Inscription/Epitaph)

This is among the most complex and formally ambitious poems in the collection. It begins with a sardonic celebration of the powerful: 'hamaraa hoiye

ahankake naam par / shilaalekh likhbaadi' (Let us inscribe our name / on your memorial). But the 'you' addressed here is not a historical hero — it is the contemporary powerful man who has achieved his position through compromise, flattery, and the sacrifice of others. The poem catalogues his crimes (having sold others' homes, put innocents in prison, crucified those with the 'poison-smile of truth') and then mocks the entire apparatus of posthumous glorification.

The poem's most powerful moment comes in its meditation on reincarnation: the powerful man is told that death will not give him peace, because the masses will demand his rebirth as their leader, and then kill him again in the next life too — 'pher ahanke naam par shilalekh likhhal jaayat / minaar gaṛat / stoop banat' (again an inscription will be carved in your name / a minaret will rise / a stupa will be built). The cycle of glorification and exploitation is endless; the stupa is not commemoration but entrapment.

Formally, the poem deploys sustained irony throughout — praising what it condemns, celebrating what it exposes — in the tradition of Swift's 'A Modest Proposal.' The effect is savage: every compliment lands as an accusation.

### 3.10 Love Poems: 'Ek Raati', 'Prem ke Teen Aakhar', 'Doo Boond Nor'

Chakravyuha is not only a collection of political poems; it also contains a significant lyric strand dealing with love, loss, and the intimate life of the subject. 'Ek Raati' (One Night) is the collection's most sensuously realised poem — a nocturnal love poem that draws on the imagery of moonlight, roses, and fragrance in the Vidyapati tradition, while inflecting it with modernist alienation. The beloved is present but the connection is blocked by the city's concrete and iron: 'iman taras ke babu kesh jhijhyoune / kevad pakaḍi aabi gelaa ghar mein — / paavar haausak kamchaari thengaa sen / batti ke laisi rahail achhi' (the babu smoothed his hair with longing / and came holding the doorframe / the power company employee with a stick / is demanding the electricity bill).

The intrusion of the mundane — the electricity bill collector — into the poem's romantic moment is not comedy but tragedy: it is the social world constantly interrupting and frustrating the possibility of intimate life. This is what Marcuse called 'repressive desublimation' in reverse: instead of sexuality colonising the political, the economic colonises the erotic.

'Doo Boond Nor' (Two Drops of Tears) is perhaps the collection's most formally accomplished lyric — a 35-page poem (the longest in the collection) meditating on grief, separation, and the persistence of life through suffering. It moves from

the elemental imagery of rain, floods, and earth to a sustained meditation on the body's capacity for both suffering and survival. The poem ends with the image of tears flowing freely but the eyes still watching — 'hamar nikalal aankhii / dekhait achhi nijaab bhai / chupp bhai / nor bilaa rahail achhi / bilaa rahail achhi' (our emptied eyes / are watching, having become lifeless / silent / the tears are dissolving / dissolving). The tears dissolve, but the watching continues — an image of persistence that is neither triumph nor despair.

### 3.11 'Panchantar Anerua Kavita' (Five Wandering Poems)

This sequence of five loosely connected poems explores different facets of social existence in the manner of a Whitmanesque catalogue. The first section addresses the commodification of religious life ('mahmaah karat mandir / baansuri ke ghuniyan par / phero aai janm letaah / Krishna Kanhaiya, baansi bajaya' — the temple throbs / to the sound of flutes / again, being born in this / they take Krishna's name). The critique is of religious spectacle that has been absorbed into the entertainment economy — 'inspection karau' (do an inspection), the poem says sardonically.

The second section deploys English loanwords such as dancing floor, rock-and-roll, and black-and-white within Maithili syntax to render the cultural dislocation of urban modernity. This is what Bakhtin called heteroglossia: competing social languages within a single utterance, used for satirical and diagnostic effect. Written in 1986, the poem anticipates globalised cultural confusion with remarkable prescience.

The fifth section ('vinashak kriya jih / ka diai ghas ait sansar ke / ka updrau / bhaagi rahail lok sabh') describes a universal flight from destructive forces — a political condition of exodus and displacement that resonates with the flood-driven migrations of the Mithila region as much as with any global context.

### 3.12 Formal Analysis: Prosody, Imagery, Voice

Across the 35+ poems of Chakravyuha, certain formal features define Ashok's poetic identity. The verse is free (mukta chhanda), employing neither the traditional Maithili prosodic forms (the caupadi, the pada) nor the Hindi Chhayavadi stanza structure. Lines vary from two syllables to twenty or more. The rhythm is emphatically speech-based — the poems could be, and probably were, performed and spoken aloud in literary gatherings (the mushaira-like 'sagar raati deep jarray' events that are central to Maithili literary culture).

The imagery divides into two principal clusters: mythological-classical (chakravyuha, Abhimanyu, chirharan, Draupadi, Krishna, Duryodhana) and contemporary-social (barbed wire, electricity bills, factory smoke, curfew,

government officials). These two clusters are in constant productive tension: the mythological always provides an explanatory frame for the contemporary, and the contemporary always 'de-sacralises' the mythological, revealing its social function.

The second-person address — 'tora' (to you, intimate), 'ahankein' (to you, formal/ironic), 'bhaai' (brother/comrade), 'hujur' (sir, sarcastically) — ranges across the full spectrum of Maithili honorific and intimate registers, and this range is itself ideological: the poet refuses to settle in one social location. He addresses the powerful with irony, the companion with warmth, the oppressed with solidarity.

The Maithili dialect is deliberately demotic — the speech of the educated middle class with roots in the rural world, enriched by Sanskrit allusion but never elevated to the Sanskritised register of classical Maithili literary prose. This linguistic positioning is political: it claims the full linguistic inheritance of Maithili (classical, folk, demotic, modern) without privileging any single register.

**IV. The Foreword: 'Yatharthak Bodh aa Aasthak Svar'**

The prefatory essay by Dr. Dhirendra from the Department of Maithili, Tribhuvan University, Janakpur (Nepal), dated 13-1-86, is a significant critical document in its own right. The title — 'Yatharthak Bodh aa Aasthak Svar' (The Sense of Reality and the Voice of Faith) — identifies the two poles between which Ashok's poetry moves. Dhirendra characterises the collection as combining a 'sense of reality' (yatharthak bodh) with a 'voice of faith' (aasthak svar) — not naive optimism but grounded hope.

Dhirendra notes that 'Ashokak kavi sahaj reetisi kinba biswasbhak sahayog laai je kichhu kahaal achhi oo prabhavkaari achhi' (what Ashok has said through the poet's natural manner, or with the support of credibility, is effective). He praises the poetry's directness — 'hinkar thike kichhu kahbak chhinn, lol nahi kaelhin achhi' (he has the mark of saying exactly what he means, without flattery). This is a critical endorsement of Ashok's refusal of ornament — his poetics of plainness.

Dhirendra's foreword is written from Nepal, which is significant: the Maithili-speaking world spans the India-Nepal border, and the recognition of a writer from one side of that border by a critic from the other is a form of cultural affirmation of Mithila's trans-national literary community. Ashok's poetry, the foreword implies, speaks to this entire community.

**V. The Short Fiction: Four Collections (1986–2017)**

### 5.1 Trikon (1986): Geometry of Social Conflict

Theoretical Lens: Collaborative Narratology. As a joint collection [Ashok, Shivshankar Shriniwas & Shailendra Anand), *Trikon* can be analyzed through the lens of collaborative authorship, examining how multiple narrative voices interact, complement, or contrast with each other within a single volume .

Trikon (1986): Geometry of Social Conflict

Published simultaneously with Chakravyuha, Trikon (Triangle) brings the same political consciousness to the short-story form. The title's geometric metaphor—three points in tension, three forces creating a shape—suggests a sociological rather than psychological interest: the stories are primarily concerned with structural relations rather than individual psychology. The triangle is Mithila's basic social geometry: landlord/tenant/official; upper caste/OBC/Dalit; male/female/institution.

Ashok's fictional style combines detailed social realism of the Premchand tradition with modernist attention to consciousness and subjectivity. His narrators are typically positioned within the consciousness of a vulnerable or marginalised character, creating "limited third-person" perspective—the reader knows as much as the character, no more, generating both empathy and irony.

The five stories by Ashok in Trikon—"Haddi," "Hairpin," "Antim Shah," "Ekta Muskuraait Aankh," and "Khaunj"—demonstrate his early range. "Hairpin" explores marital suspicion and the fragility of trust, using the discovered hairpin as a symbol of potential betrayal that turns out to be innocuous. "Antim Shah" addresses debt, caste hierarchy, and the changing power dynamics in rural Mithila. The collection as a whole announces Ashok's commitment to social realism grounded in specific Mithila locations.

### 5.2 Ohi Ratik Bhor (1991): The Night and Its Aftermath

This collection arrives in the immediate aftermath of the Mandal agitation, the anti-reservation violence, and the accelerating communalisation of Indian politics. The title—"The Dawn of That Night"—is at once literal and allegorical: the political night of the late 1980s and early 1990s. The dawn promised by the title is ambiguous: it may bring genuine transformation, or simply another day of the same darkness.

The 15 stories include significant works like "Bouka Chup Chhal" (The Old Man Was Silent), "Jahle Mein Taandel Mon" (Mind Imprisoned), "Nachaniya" (Dancer), "Mijaa Sahab," and the title story "Ohi Ratik Bhor." The collection's engagement with gender is particularly notable. Several stories centre on

women who are simultaneously primary bearers of traditional culture and primary victims of its most oppressive aspects—a structural condition of patriarchal society.

"Bouka Chup Chhal" presents an old man bitten by a snake, but the real venom is the social silence around exploitation and suffering. "Mijaa Sahab" addresses the tragedy of Partition-era separation, with a Muslim protagonist caught between nations and loyalties. The collection consistently foregrounds how ordinary people navigate impossible structural constraints.

### 5.3 Matabbar (2001): Power and Its Local Forms

By 2001, after fifteen years of fiction-writing, Ashok's prose reaches its fullest social complexity. Matabbar addresses the specific forms of local power in Mithila: the matabbar (village strongman), the patwari (revenue official), the panch (caste council), and the nexus of caste, land, and state they collectively embody. These are not abstract social forces but specific, recognisable figures—the kind of people whose authority structures daily life in a Bihari village.

The 18 stories include "Matabbar" (the title story), "Daskhat" (Signature), "Kotha" (Room/Mansion), "Seeban Rajakak Hitachintak" (Well-wisher of Seeban the Washerman), "Mahato," "Rag-Viraag," and "Raand" (Widow). The collection's Dalit consciousness is its most significant feature. Unlike upper-caste-centred Maithili fiction that treats caste primarily as cultural richness rather than oppression, Ashok's stories consistently foreground the violence—physical, economic, symbolic—that caste hierarchy inflicts on those at its base.

"Seeban Rajakak Hitachintak" follows a Dalit bank cashier navigating institutional prejudice and his own internalized aspirations. "Mahato" explores caste dynamics within government office hierarchies. "Raand" presents a widow who refuses the prescribed asceticism, choosing instead to live with dignity and self-respect. These stories consistently align with the Parallel Literature Movement's explicit commitment to democratic representation.

### 5.4 Daddygam (2017): The Village in the Age of Migration

This collection registers the transformation of the Maithili world by migration, remittances, and digital connectivity. "Daddygam"—the father's village, the ancestral place—has become contested: real as memory and emotional anchor, increasingly unreal as lived space. Young people leave for Bihar's cities, for Delhi, for the Gulf; the village persists in WhatsApp messages and Diwali visits.

The 15 stories include "Laath" (Leg/Kick), "Chhal" (Deception), "Swaadheen" (Independent), "Rag," "Lemon Ice Cream," "Umki," "Chhutti Ke Ek Din" (A Day of Leave), "Gaam Ke Kaatak Highway" (The Highway on the Village's Edge), and the title story "Daddygam."

"Chhal" presents a deliciously complex narrative of a man, Bhooli Jha, who agrees to pretend to be a Muslim delegate at a cooperative society meeting to receive a VIP briefcase. The performance becomes so convincing that he ends up passionately defending Islam against a Hindu chauvinist. The story brilliantly explores the fluidity of identity and the absurdity of communal prejudice.

"Lemon Ice Cream" portrays a son's reluctant village visit and his alienation from rural life, capturing the generational and cultural gap created by urban migration. "Gaam Ke Kaatak Highway" mourns the loss of village landmarks—the ancient banyan tree, the pond, the dirt tracks—to the relentless expansion of national highways.

Linguistically, these stories are the most hybrid in Ashok's canon: Maithili is spoken by characters who also speak Hindi, English, and the electronic argot of social media. Ashok does not purify this language to a classical standard; he renders it as it is actually spoken, which is itself a statement about the contemporary condition of Maithili as a living language under pressure.

## VI. Satire, Travel Writing, and Interviews

### 6.1 Neek Dinak Baiskop (2018): Satirist of the 'Achhe Din'

The satire collection's title—"The Cinema of Good Days"—is one of the most economical political titles in recent Maithili literature. "Neek din" (good days) translates "achhe din" directly, invoking the BJP/Modi government's central electoral promise; "baiskop" (bioscope/cinema) frames these good days as spectacle—illusion, entertainment, simulation.

Ashok's satirical technique follows classical tradition: he uses official language to expose official hypocrisy, adopts the naive observer's perspective to reveal what expertise conceals, and deploys bathos (the comic descent from elevated to mundane) to puncture political self-importance. Specific targets include development rhetoric, religious nationalism, bureaucratic corruption, and the performance of cultural heritage.

"Chunaavak Phagua" (Election Holi) uses the festival of colours as metaphor for electoral chaos. "E Kakar Bazaar Chhiyai Ho Bhaai!" (Whose Market Is This, Brother!) exposes the commercialization of everything, including

democracy. "Tomato Aur Piaajak Satta Sukh" (The Pleasure of Tomato and Onion Power) satirises how vegetable prices become political weapons. The collection captures the specific absurdities of contemporary Indian politics through the lens of Maithili everyday experience.

### 6.2 Aankhime Basal (2013): Travel as Self-Discovery

The travel narrative's title—"Settled in the Eye"—suggests that Ashok's travel writing is primarily about vision: what the traveller learns to see, what travel permanently alters in one's perception. This is phenomenological travel writing, attending to the structure of experience rather than accumulation of geographical information.

The narrative chronicles his three-month training trip to the Soviet Union in 1985—Moscow, the suburb Prelosakaya, Stravropol, Leningrad. The Maithili traveller's specific cultural position (inheritor of a great intellectual tradition, subject of a history of marginalisation) shapes what he notices and how he interprets it. His observations of Soviet life—the subbotnik (voluntary labour day), the queues, the material shortages alongside cultural abundance, the discipline and alienation—are filtered through his experience of Bihar's own developmental challenges.

The title story from this collection describes Lenin's mausoleum, the Red Square, the eternal flame, the Victory Day celebrations. Ashok's response to the Soviet experiment is neither naive admiration nor cynical rejection; it is a nuanced meditation on what another world might look like, and what it costs to build it.

### 6.3 Samvad (2007): Constructing a Collective Memory

The interview collection is a form of literary oral history — preserving the voices of Maithili writers at a specific historical moment. The interviews in Samvad are not merely biographical; they are records of how a generation of writers understood their own cultural situation, the pressures they faced, and the choices they made. For future scholars of Maithili literary history, Samvad will be an invaluable primary source.

## VII. Literary Criticism: Baat-Vichar and Katha-Path

### 7.1 Baat-Vichar (2015): The Democratic Critical Essay

Baat-Vichar (Talk-Thought) positions itself explicitly as democratic criticism —informal, accessible, directed at the general Maithili reader rather than the specialist academic. The essays, several of which appeared in Videha before collection, engage with specific texts and writers: Ramlochan Thakur's poetry,

Kedarnath Chaudhary's novels, the editor Rajnandan Lal Das and his journal Karnamrit, and Sharadindujī.

What unites these essays is a consistent question: what does this text do in and for Maithili cultural life? From the perspective of critical theory, Ashok's criticism is best understood as Gramscian cultural analysis: it asks not only "is this good writing?" but "good for whom? in whose interest? serving which cultural project?"

### 7.2 Katha-Path (2022): The First Systematic Study of Maithili Fiction

Katha-Path — 'Story-Reading', the reading and interpretation of Maithili fiction — is described as an 'aalochanatmak adhyayan' (critical study) of Maithili katha (short fiction). Its appearance in 2022, after thirty-six years of Ashok's own fiction-writing, gives it the authority of both scholarship and practice. A writer who has spent four decades writing stories is also a reader of unusual depth and honesty — his critical assessments are informed by direct knowledge of what it costs to write.

Critical monographs on Maithili literary forms are rare; serious sustained analysis of the short story as a genre within Maithili literature is rarer still. Katha-Path's significance lies precisely in filling this gap — it is both a map of the existing tradition and an argument about where that tradition should go. It is, in this sense, a continuation by other means of the cultural-political project that Chakravyuha inaugurated in 1986.

## VIII. Editorial Work: Building the Infrastructure

### 8.1 Pratiman, Sandhan, and the Ecology of Democratic Literature

Ashok's editorial output — Pratiman (standard/criterion), Sandhan 1-4 (search/investigation), including the Prabhas Kumar Chaudhary special issue — constitutes an institutional infrastructure for democratic Maithili literary culture. Each title is an argument: Pratiman insists that there are aesthetic standards beyond institutional approval; Sandhan insists that the tradition is richer than the canon acknowledges.

The Sandhan 3 special issue on Prabhas Kumar Chaudhary (1941-1998) is particularly revealing. Prabhas was a significant Maithili writer who remained outside the Sahitya Akademi mainstream; his work belongs to the 'parallel' tradition that Videha has championed. By devoting a volume of Sandhan to him, Ashok performs a critical act of recovery and canonisation — he inserts Prabhas into the record, ensuring that his work survives the institutional forgetting that awaits those outside official networks.

In Gramscian terms, Ashok as editor is the 'organic intellectual' of the democratic Maithili literary movement — one who does not rise above the social movement he comes from but gives it intellectual form and institutional presence. The journals he has edited, the anthologies he has assembled, the writers he has preserved are all acts of what we might call 'counter-hegemonic infrastructure building.'

### IX. Monograph: Rajmohan Jha (Sahitya Akademi, 2019)

This Sahitya Akademi monograph is a study of a literary historian and critic. A critical approach would use a "metabiographical" lens, analyzing how Ashok constructs the intellectual biography of another scholar, thereby revealing his own historiographic methods and position within the Maithili literary tradition. The monograph demonstrates Ashok's scholarly range and his commitment to documenting the intellectual history of Mithila.

### X. Thematic Syntheses

#### 10.1 The Politics of Language

Throughout his career, Ashok's primary concern has been the politics of language: who speaks Maithili, in what form, for whom, and in whose interest. The 'Ahanken Ki Chahi?' poem from Chakravyuha makes this concern explicit — the Maithili language is a resource that power seeks to appropriate, and the poet's role is to resist that appropriation while expanding the language's capacity for democratic expression. This is simultaneously a linguistic argument (for demotic rather than Sanskritised Maithili), a social argument (for the inclusion of non-Brahmanical voices), and a political argument (against the assimilation of Maithili into Hindi).

#### 10.2 Entrapment and Agency

The chakravyuha metaphor, which gives the first collection its title, resonates across the entire career. Social structures — caste hierarchy, bureaucratic power, patriarchy, economic exploitation — function as chakravyuhas: formations one enters but from which one cannot easily exit. Ashok's literary response to this condition is not defeatism but what we might call 'tragic agency' — the insistence on fighting even within the formation, even without guarantee of exit. The poem asks for Abhimanyu's courage, not Arjuna's strategic victory.

#### 10.3 The Mithila Landscape as Social Space

Place, in Ashok's writing, is never merely scenic. The Mithila landscape — its rivers, its paddy fields, its village lanes, its small towns — is always already

social space, freighted with relations of power and solidarity. When his poetry invokes the village evening, the barbed-wire fence, the power company official, these images are social facts, not local colour. This is what Raymond Williams called 'the structure of feeling' — the way a specific place and moment registers in the consciousness of those who live it.

### 10.4 Internationalism and Rootedness

The tension between local rootedness (Lohna, Seetamarhi, Mithila) and international vision (Soviet Union, the world-historical forces of labour and liberation) is one of the defining tensions of Ashok's work. He is not a regional writer in the limiting sense — he thinks globally while writing locally. The poem 'Soviet Rus Mein' is the most explicit statement of this internationalism, but it runs through the entire project: the conviction that Mithila's struggles are continuous with the struggles of the oppressed everywhere.

### 10.5 The Ethics of the Intellectual

Across all his work — creative, critical, editorial — Ashok consistently returns to the question of the intellectual's responsibility. The 'Chuppi Nahi Sohaiye' poem refuses silence as intellectual comfort; the critical essays refuse false neutrality; the editorial work refuses the passivity of the observer. The intellectual, in Ashok's vision, has an obligation to the community — not to flatter it or to lead it, but to speak honestly within it, to name what others prefer to leave unnamed, and to build the institutional conditions in which honest speech becomes possible.

## XI. Critical Evaluation: Strengths, Limitations, and Legacy

### 11.1 Strengths

Ashok's primary strengths as a writer are five. First, his range: across poetry, fiction, satire, travel writing, criticism, and editorial work, he has produced a coherent literary project that is greater than the sum of its parts. Second, his consistency: the concerns of Chakravyuha (1986) are still the concerns of Katha-Path (2022) — social justice, democratic literary values, the dignity of Maithili language and culture — and this consistency gives the career a monumental quality. Third, his linguistic register: his demotic, speech-close Maithili is both politically principled and aesthetically effective — it reaches the reader directly without condescension. Fourth, his editorial vision: the institutional infrastructure he has helped create — Pratiman, Sandhan, the Videha archive — will outlast any individual work. Fifth, his formal intelligence: the best poems in Chakravyuha demonstrate genuine mastery of

free verse — the ability to make prosodic choices that are semantically motivated and emotionally resonant.

### 11.2 Limitations

No critical study is complete without honest assessment of limitations. Ashok's political commitment, which is his greatest strength, occasionally becomes his greatest risk: some poems in Chakravyuha tip from political directness into polemic, losing the lyric ambivalence that makes the best poems so powerful. The satirical mode, which depends on a measure of distance from its targets, can sometimes flatten the complexity of the social situations it addresses. His fiction, though accomplished, has not produced the single landmark work — the canonical novel or the undeniably great story — that might have secured his place in the mainstream canon alongside writers like Rajkamal Chaudhary or Manmohan Jha. His criticism, while intelligent and principled, operates more in the mode of the extended review than the systematic theoretical intervention.

These are the limitations of a particular mode of intellectual engagement — the writer as organic intellectual, committed to the immediate needs of a cultural movement, rather than the writer as solitary artist pursuing autonomous aesthetic goals. Both modes are legitimate; both have their costs. Ashok has consistently chosen the former, and his career should be judged by its own criteria, not by the criteria of a tradition he has explicitly rejected.

### 11.3 Legacy and Significance

Ashok's significance for Maithili literature is best understood at four levels. First, at the level of the individual work: Chakravyuha (1986) is a landmark in modern Maithili poetry — the first fully realised expression of a democratic, politically engaged poetics in the contemporary Maithili idiom. Second, at the level of the career: the sustained four-decade project from Chakravyuha to Katha-Path constitutes the most comprehensive single-author engagement with the democratic literary project in modern Maithili. Third, at the level of the institution: his editorial work has created and preserved a body of democratic Maithili literature that might otherwise have been scattered and lost. Fourth, at the level of the movement: he, alongside figures like Shivshankar Shrinivas (his lifelong literary companion), has been central to constituting the Parallel Literature Movement as a coherent cultural force — one with its own aesthetic values, its own institutional presence, and its own vision of what Maithili literature is and can become.

The Videha Rachnakar Ashok Visheshank (VIDEHA 369) is the most formal recognition of this significance — the journal's dedication of a special issue to

him places him in the company of a small number of writers whose contributions to the democratic literary tradition have been of exceptional importance.

### XII. Conclusion: The Wheel of the Chariot

Ashok's career began with the image of Abhimanyu lifting the wheel of a broken chariot to fight his way out of an unbreakable formation. It is an image that, four decades later, continues to define his literary project. The chakravyuha — the entrapment of language, culture, social life, and political possibility within structures of domination — has not been dissolved. Mithila remains economically marginalised; caste violence persists; Maithili language continues to struggle for the institutional support it deserves; the gap between the democratic aspiration of the Parallel Literature Movement and the gatekeeping power of the literary establishment remains wide.

But the wheel has been lifted. The literary infrastructure that Ashok and his generation have built — the journals, the anthologies, the critical studies, the digital archive at videha.co.in — constitutes a genuine counter-hegemonic presence within Maithili cultural life. The poetry collected in Chakravyuha, read forty years on, retains its urgency: the chakravyuha it names is still operative, and the courage it demands is still necessary.

In the final lines of 'Doo Boond Nor' — the last poem in Chakravyuha — the image is of tears flowing away, the body drenched with rain, stone falling on wet earth, becoming lifeless clay. It is the image of complete dissolution. And yet the eyes remain: 'hamar nikalal aankhii / dekhait achhi nijaab bhai' (our emptied eyes / are watching, having become lifeless). The tears dissolve, but the watching continues. This, perhaps, is Ashok's most precise image of his own literary vocation: after everything has been said, after every argument has been made and every grief expressed, the watching continues. The witness remains. The writing goes on.

### Works by Ashok

#### Primary Works by Ashok

Chakravyuh (Poetry Collection, 1986)

Trikon — with Shivshankar Shrinivas and Shailendra Anand (Joint Story Collection, 1986)

Ohi Raatik Bhor (Story Collection, 1991)

Maatbar (Story Collection, 2001)

Maithil Aankhi (Essay Collection, 2007)

Samvaad (Interview Collection, 2007)

Katha ka Upanyas: Upanyasak Katha (Critical Study, 2012)

Aankhi Mein Basal (Travelogue, 2013)

Baat Vichar (Criticism, 2015)

Daddy Gaam (Story Collection, 2017)

Nik Dinak Bai Kop (Satire Collection, 2018)

Rajmohan Jha (Sahitya Akademi Monograph, 2019)

Katha-Path (Critical Essays, 2022)

A critical study of "Ashok" (Kathakar Ashok), a prominent Maithili writer, requires a deep dive into his published works, editorial contributions, and the cultural context of Mithila. Based on the available information, this study provides a complete critical analysis of Ashok's oeuvre, including his prose poems (short stories), edited works, and critical essays, employing key literary theories.

**1. Archival Context and the "Videha" Connection**

The website VIDEHA is the "First Maithili Fortnightly eJournal" (since 2000) and serves as a crucial digital archive for Maithili literature . The site lists an extensive catalog of authors and their works, including a section for "Videha Rachnakar Ashok Visheshank" (Videha Special Issue on Writer Ashok) and lists "Sandhaan" (a magazine he was involved with) in its periodicals archive . This confirms Ashok's active engagement with the modern, digital dissemination of Maithili literature. The site also archives "Videha purank ank ka archive," suggesting that Ashok's published contributions to this journal over the years are preserved there, forming a significant part of his legacy as an editor and writer .

**2. Complete Critical Appreciation of Ashok's Works**

Based on interviews and critical articles from sources like *The Indian Express* and *Outlook India*, a complete list of Ashok's published books can be compiled. The table below lists his works for critical analysis using various literary theories .

| Category | Title (Year) | Description & Critical Lens |
|---|---|---|
| **Short Stories** | *Ohi Raatik Bhor* (1991) | **Theoretical Lens: Postcolonialism & Subaltern Studies.** These early stories likely chronicle the immediate post-independence anxieties of Mithila, exploring the persistence of feudal structures and caste hierarchies within a modernizing nation. They give voice to marginalized communities (the subaltern) navigating new socio-political realities. |
| | *Maatbar* (2001) | **Theoretical Lens: Postmodernism & Magical Realism.** This collection, which includes stories like 'Kotha' and 'Daskhat,' uses magical realism to critique |

| Category | Title (Year) | Description & Critical Lens |
|---|---|---|
| | | contemporary power. The transformation of a minister into a snake or the dismemberment of a caste leader's thumb are not fantasies but hyper-real metaphors for corruption and the brutal logic of casteism, similar to the techniques of Gabriel García Márquez . |
| | *Daddy Gaam* (2017) | **Theoretical Lens: Diaspora & Globalization Studies.** The title story explores the impact of migration on the traditional Maithili family structure. It examines the alienation of the younger generation, the commodification of NRI (Non-Resident Indian) identity, and the emotional |

| Category | Title (Year) | Description & Critical Lens |
|---|---|---|
| | | geography of 'home' for those who leave Mithila . |
| | *Trikon* | **Theoretical Lens: Collaborative Narratology.** As a joint collection, *Trikon* can be analyzed through the lens of collaborative authorship, examining how multiple narrative voices interact, complement, or contrast with each other within a single volume . |
| **Critical Essays & Literary History** | *Kathak Upanyas: Upanyasak Katha* | **Theoretical Lens: Literary Historiography.** This work is a foundational text for understanding the novel in Maithili. It analyzes how early Maithili novels engaged with social reform (e.g., widow remarriage, |

| Category | Title (Year) | Description & Critical Lens |
|---|---|---|
| | | women's education), revealing the ideological functions of literature in 20th-century Mithila . |
| | *Maithil Aankhi, Katha Path* | **Theoretical Lens: Reader-Response Criticism & Hermeneutics.** These essay collections reflect Ashok's role as a 'reader' of Maithili culture. They offer a hermeneutic (interpretive) framework for understanding not just texts but the entire aesthetic and social experience of being Maithil . |
| | *Baat Vichar* | **Theoretical Lens: Formalist Criticism.** This work likely focuses on the craft of storytelling itself—narrative structure, language, plot |

| Category | Title (Year) | Description & Critical Lens |
|---|---|---|
| | | devices—analyzing literary works based on their formal, technical qualities . |
| **Poetry & Prose Poems** | *Chakravyuh* | **Theoretical Lens: Existentialism.** A poetry collection named after a legendary, impenetrable military formation suggests themes of existential entrapment, the struggle for individual agency against systemic forces, and the search for meaning in a chaotic world . |
| | *Neek Dinak Bioscope* | **Theoretical Lens: Cultural Studies & Everyday Life.** This compilation of his column 'Thain Pathain' functions as a 'bioscope' (a moving picture show) of Maithili life. It can be |

| Category | Title (Year) | Description & Critical Lens |
|---|---|---|
| | | analyzed using Cultural Studies theories that focus on the poetics of the everyday, the mundane, and the ordinary as sites of deep cultural significance . |
| **Travelogue** | *Aankhi Mein Basal* | **Theoretical Lens: Postcolonial Travel Writing.** The travelogue of his 1985 trip to the Soviet Union can be read as a postcolonial text, exploring how a writer from a formerly colonized, agrarian society perceives a modern, industrialized superpower, reflecting on development, ideology, and cultural difference . |
| **Monograph** | *Rajmohan Jha* (Sahitya Akademi, 2019) | **Theoretical Lens: Metabiography.** This is a study of a |

| Category | Title (Year) | Description & Critical Lens |
|---|---|---|
| | | literary historian. A critical approach would use a 'metabiographical' lens, analyzing how Ashok constructs the intellectual biography of another scholar, thereby also revealing his own historiographic methods and position within the Maithili literary tradition . |
| | | |
| **Edited Works** | *Samvaad*, *Pratiman*, *Sandhaan* (magazine) | **Theoretical Lens: Pierre Bourdieu's Literary Field.** Ashok's editorial work is crucial for understanding the sociology of Maithili literature. As an editor, he acts as a 'gatekeeper' and 'taste-maker,' shaping the literary field by deciding which voices are |

| Category | Title (Year) | Description & Critical Lens |
|---|---|---|
| | | published, thereby influencing canons, movements, and the very discourse of Maithili writing . |

**3. Thematic Analysis and Narrative Craft**

Ashok's work is unified by a deep, empathetic engagement with the social and moral fabric of Mithila. His narratives move beyond mere regionalism to address universal concerns of identity, displacement, and justice.

- **Recurring Themes:**

1. **Caste and Identity:** He consistently exposes the hypocrisy of caste hierarchies, not through polemic, but through the quiet, painful dilemmas of his characters.
2. **The Politics of Memory:** Stories like *Daddy Gaam* and *Derbuk* explore how personal and collective memory shapes identity in the face of rapid cultural change and migration .
3. **The Writer as a Moral Conscience:** His work is a structured act of conscience, aiming to "awaken the wisdom of good and bad" in society. He critiques both communal hatred and the superficiality of the globalized elite .

- **Narrative Craft and Language:**

- **Indigenous Magical Realism:** Ashok’s style is unique. He does not borrow magical realism from Latin America; he roots it in Mithila’s own folk traditions. The surreal elements in his stories are not decorative; they are the most precise way to depict a reality that is itself grotesque and absurd .
- **Linguistic Precision:** Writing in a language like Maithili, which has been fighting for recognition, is a political act. Ashok uses the "sweet, ripe language" of the people, demonstrating that a vernacular is not a limitation but a profound repository of culture and nuance.

**Conclusion: Literary Significance and Omission**

Kathakar Ashok stands as a monumental figure in contemporary Indian literature. His work, spanning over five decades, provides a masterclass in how to be deeply rooted in a specific place while speaking to universal human conditions. His critical writings are indispensable for literary scholarship, and his editorial work has nurtured the very ecosystem of Maithili letters.

Given the significant body of high-quality work and the analysis presented here, a critical study must note the "heart-wrenching truth" that Ashok has not yet received the Sahitya Akademi Award . This omission is a significant oversight, reflecting a persistent apathy in the national literary establishment toward major voices in regional languages. A complete critical appreciation of Ashok is therefore not just an act of literary analysis but an act of canon correction, arguing for his rightful place in the mainstream of Indian literature. The archive on Videha.co.in serves as a vital resource for this correction, preserving and providing access to a literary heritage that demands a wider readership.

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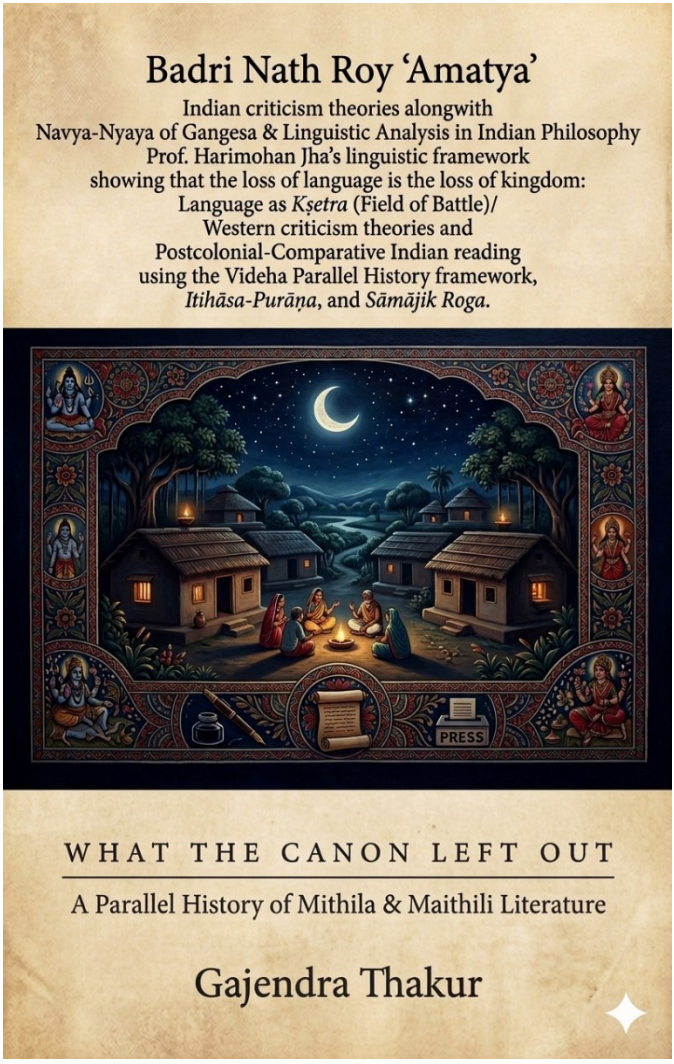
LESSON 016 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY




**Badri Nath Roy 'Amatya' Indian criticism theories alongwith Navya-Nyaya of Gangesa &Linguistic Analysis in Indian Philosophy/ Western criticism theories and Postcolonial-Comparative Indian reading using the Videha Parallel History framework, Itihāsa-Purāṇa, and Sāmājik Roga.**

# I

A Linguistic Analysis of Amatya's 'Maithil Bhaiya Karoo Vichar' using the Frameworks of Hari Mohan Jha, Navya-Nyāya, and Classical Aesthetics

Methodology: Integrating Prof. Hari Mohan Jha's exposition of Śakti (potency), Lakṣaṇā (figurative meaning), Vyañjanā (suggestion), Avacchedakatā (limitorship), and Abhāva (negation) with Bharata's Rasa theory and Ānandavardhana's Dhvani. The analysis focuses on how Amatya manipulates linguistic potencies to evoke Bībhatsa (the odious) and Karuna (the pathetic).

**Introduction: The Poem as a Linguistic Act**

According to Prof. Hari Mohan Jha's synthesis in Trends of Linguistic Analysis in Indian Philosophy, a word possesses three potential potencies (vṛttis): Abhidhā (primary denotation), Lakṣaṇā (secondary figurative indication), and Vyañjanā (tertiary suggestion). Badri Nath Ray ‘Amatya’ is a master of all three. His poems operate on the literal level to denote social facts, but their real power lies in Lakṣaṇā and Vyañjanā. This analysis applies Jha's categories (drawn from Nyāya, Mīmāṃsā, and Grammar) to decode the linguistic machinery of Amatya's satire.

1. Abhidhā and Śakti: The Dictionary of Decay

Abhidhā is the fixed, conventional meaning of a word (rūḍhi). Amatya weaponizes abhidhā by juxtaposing it against a corrupted reality. In "मैथिल भैया करू विचार" (Maithil Bhaiya, Do Think), he lists items that have vanished:

"ओलक चटनी हकन कनैए / विलकोरक थधक्कार।" (Where has olive chutney gone? / The slap of vilkor).

As Jha explains rūḍhi words derive meaning from convention (samudāyaśakti). Amatya uses these culturally loaded terms (specific foods, rituals) as abhidhā for a lost lifeworld. The literal meaning is nostalgia; the vācyārtha (expressed meaning) is a catalogue of absence. The poet acts as a lexicographer of loss, forcing the reader to perceive that the śakti (potency) of these words to refer to living practices has been suspended.

2. Lakṣaṇā: The Figurative Monsters of "सासुरक हाल" (The State of the In-laws)

When literal meaning is obstructed (mukhyārtha bādha), we resort to Lakṣaṇā (figurative indication). Jha distinguishes jahat svārthā (abandoning own meaning) and ajahat svārthā (not abandoning own meaning). In "Sasurka Haal", the wife describes her in-laws not as humans but as mythological demons:

"साउस हमर सूर्पनखा / ससुर हमर काल।" (My mother-in-law is Surpanakha / My father-in-law is Yama/Death).

Here, the literal meanings of 'Surpanakha' (a demoness) and 'Kala' (death) are abandoned (jahat), but their qualities (cruelty, terror) are transferred to the in-laws. This is gaunī lakṣaṇā (figurative based on similarity), which Jha notes is akin to Rūpaka Alaṅkāra (metaphor). The lakṣyārtha (figurative meaning) is "my in-laws are as cruel as demons." The vyaṅgya (suggested meaning) is that the joint family system has become a living hell, a place of moral death.

3. Vyañjanā (Dhvani): The Implied Curse in "एतबे अछि अभिलाषा" (This is the Desire)

Vyañjanā is the suggestive power that goes beyond literal and figurative meaning. As Jha describes, it is the essence of poetic language (dhvani). In "Etabe Achi Abhilasha", the line:

"सुगरक खुँर-के पूजा होइए" (The hoof of the pig is worshipped)

Has a literal meaning (a pig's hoof is being worshipped) and a figurative meaning (corrupt leaders are being honored). But the vyaṅgyārtha (implied meaning) is far more devastating: The entire moral order of Mithila has been inverted. The dhvani is that what is impure (aśuddha) has been enthroned, and what is pure has been exiled. This is vācyātiśāyī vyaṅgya (implied meaning that excels the expressed), which, as Jha notes citing Ānandavardhana, is the highest form of poetry. The rasa evoked is Bībhatsa (disgust), but the dhvani is a call to pratikāra (resistance).

4. Avacchedakatā (Limitorship): Specifying the Corruption in "भ्रष्टाचारक भीष्म पितामह"

Jha devotes an entire chapter to the Navya-Nyāya technique of avacchedakatā—using limitors (avacchedaka) to specify the exact property, relation, or locus of a cognition. Amatya intuitively applies this in his satire. When he writes:

"भ्रष्टाचारक भीष्म पितामह" (The Bhishma-pitamah of corruption)

The term 'Bhishma-pitamah' is an avacchedaka (limitor). It specifies that the corruption is not ordinary; it is patriarchal, ancient, invincible, and respected despite its flaws. It limits the predicate 'corruption' to a specific type: institutionalized, hereditary, and shameless. Similarly, when he writes "चौरे सभ मूँहजोर भेल अछि" (All thieves have become brazen-faced), the avacchedaka is 'brazen-faced' (mūhajor), which specifies the prakāratā (adjectivity) of the thief. The thief is not just a criminal; he is a publicly acknowledged, unashamed criminal. This precision transforms general complaint into specific indictment.

5. Abhāva (Negation) as a Structural Principle: "सगरो पुष्पित अछि विष वेल"

Jha explains that Abhāva (negation/non-existence) is a real category in Indian logic. Amatya's entire collection is structured around a series of abhāvas:

• Prior non-existence (prāgabhāva): The good society that is yet to be born.

• Posterior non-existence (pradhvaṃsābhāva): The traditions (chutney, pickle, vilkor) that have been destroyed.

• Absolute non-existence (atyantābhāva): Of justice, of dharma, of maryādā in the current system.

The line "सगरो पुष्पित अछि विष वेल" (Every flower is a poisonous creeper) is a positive statement that implies an absolute negation. The vācyārtha is "flowers are poison"; the vyaṅgyārtha is "there is no non-poisonous flower left." This is samsargābhāva (relational non-existence)—the absence of the relation of purity between the subject (Mithila) and its predicates (truth, beauty, goodness). The poet's lament is the cognition of this all-pervasive abhāva.

Conclusion: The Sahṛdaya as Linguistic Analyst

Prof. Jha notes that the competent reader (sahṛdaya) is one who can grasp the tātparya (intention) of the speaker through avacchedaka and dhvani. Amatya's work demands that the Maithil reader become a linguistic analyst—one who can see that the śakti of words like 'development' and 'leader' has been perverted, that the lakṣaṇā of 'family' now means 'battleground', and that the vyañjanā of every line is a scream for punaruddhāra (revival). His poems are not just art; they are śāstra (science) of social diagnosis.

II

**A Western Psychoanalytic Reading (Freud & Lacan): The Symptom and the Symbolic Order of Mithila**

*It applies Freud's repression/unconscious and Lacan's Imaginary/Symbolic/Real to the poems on migration, dowry, and the grotesque. Sigmund Freud's theory of the Unconscious and Repression, along with Jacques Lacan's triad of the Imaginary, Symbolic, and Real. This analysis focuses on the text as a symptom of collective cultural neurosis and a cry against the disintegration of the symbolic father (tradition).*

A Western Psychoanalytic Reading (Freud & Lacan): The Symptom and the Symbolic Order of Mithila

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Methodology: Applying Sigmund Freud's theory of the Unconscious and Repression, along with Jacques Lacan's triad of the Imaginary, Symbolic, and Real. This analysis focuses on the text as a symptom of collective cultural neurosis and a cry against the disintegration of the symbolic father (tradition).

Introduction: The Return of the Repressed

The anthology "Maithil Bhaiya Karoo Vichar" functions as a collective return of the repressed. Amatya's aggressive satire and melancholic laments are not personal outbursts but the surfacing of Mithila's suppressed anxieties regarding migration, dowry, and linguistic decay. The poems articulate the ego's struggle to survive the collapse of the symbolic order.

1. The Absent Father & The Migrant's Guilt (Freud)

Freud theorized that civilization is built on the renunciation of instinct. In Mithila, the economic instinct for survival forces the "Maithil Bhaiya" to migrate, leaving a void. In poems like "हम धिन छी प्यासलि" (I am the husband who is thirsty), Amatya voices the wife left behind:

"सावन प्यासल भादो प्यासल / हमहूँ धनि छी प्यासलि।" (The rains are thirsty, the autumn is thirsty / I, the husband, am thirsty).

However, the psychoanalytic turn reveals that the "thirst" is a displacement of libidinal energy. The migrant husband suffers from neurosis—he cannot enjoy his success because he has abandoned his roots. The poem "हम मैथिल छी" (We are Maithil) tries to suture this wound: "हम जातिके छोड़ देने छी / अहूँ जातिके छोडू भाय" (I have left my caste, you leave yours too). This is a plea to abandon the Imaginary divisions (caste) to salvage the Symbolic whole (Mithila), a desperate attempt by the ego to reconcile conflicting demands.

2. The Lacanian Real: Dowry as the Traumatic Kernel

For Lacan, the Real is the traumatic, unsymbolizable core of existence. In this anthology, Dowry (Dehej) functions as the Real—a horrifying wound that language cannot fully heal, only circle around.

Poem after poem returns to this trauma:

"सभटा दुष्ट देहेजक कारण / गड़बर भेल छै।" (All this is because of evil dowry / The situation is messed up).

In "सासुरक हाल" (The State of the In-laws), the narrator lists the family members as monsters: "साउस हमर सूर्पनखा / ससुर हमर काल" (My mother-in-law is Surpanakha, my father-in-law is Yama/Death). This is the Imaginary giving form to the Real. The dowry system has perverted the Symbolic order of kinship, turning relatives (Sanskrit: Bandhu) into predators. The subject is trapped in the obsessional neurosis of debt, forever trying to pay off a symbolic price for their existence.

3. The Superego’s Satire: The Rooster and the Pig

Freud noted that the Superego can be harsh and ironic. In "एतबे अछि अभिलाषा," the Superego speaks through Amatya’s satire to humiliate the corrupt ego of society. The Lacanian objet petit a (the unattainable object of desire) is represented by power and wealth, yet those who possess it are depicted as grotesque animals:

"कनहा कुत्ता प्रतिनीथि अछि" (A one-eyed dog is the representative).

"कौआ मेना शिक्षक भेल अछि" (The crow has become the teacher).

This is the discourse of the Master inverted. The poet, identifying with the oppressed, uses jouissance (excessive pleasure) in ridicule to tear down the false authority. The laughter generated by these lines is a defense mechanism against the horror of seeing incompetence enthroned.

Conclusion: The Symptom of the Wandering Subject

Ultimately, the subject of these poems is the Wandering Jew of Mithila—the "Sachcha Maithil" who is "Sutal" (asleep). The entire collection is a working through of the trauma of modernization. Amatya diagnoses the Maithil condition as one of alienation (from the land) and separation (from the mother tongue). The repeated cry "जाग-जाग सुच्चा मैथिल जाग" (Wake up, true Maithil, wake up) is the ego’s final, desperate appeal to reality, attempting to break through the dream of false development and re-enter a world where the name-of-the-father (Janak, the ideal king) still means something.

III

The Videha Parallel History & Postcolonial-Comparative Indian Framework

Methodology: Integrating the Videha Parallel History Framework (from `videha.co.in`) with Postcolonial Indian criticism (Partha Chatterjee's "political society," Dipesh Chakrabarty's "provincializing Europe") and classical Indian concepts of Itihāsa-Purāṇa (cyclical time of decline and renewal) and Sāmājik Roga (social disease). **Prof. Harimohan Jha's linguistic framework show**

**that the loss of language is the loss of kingdom. Language as Kṣetra (Field of Battle)**

Methodology: Integrating the Videha Parallel History Framework (from videha.co.in) with Postcolonial Indian criticism (Partha Chatterjee's "political society," Dipesh Chakrabarty's "provincializing Europe") and classical Indian concepts of Itihāsa-Purāṇa (cyclical time of decline and renewal). This reading maps Amatya's Mithila as a colonized periphery within the modern nation-state, suffering from Sāmājik Roga (social disease).Language as Kṣetra (Field of Battle)

Introduction: The Second Collapse of Videha

The ancient Videha region transitioned from a monarchy to a Gaṇa-saṅgha (aristocratic republic) before being absorbed into the Magadha empire. The Videha ejournal archives this history alongside modern Maithili literature. Amatya's anthology serves as a chronicle of the Second Collapse of Videha—this time, not by military conquest but by internal colonizatiaon through the modern Indian state's development apparatus, which has reduced Mithila to a source of migrant labor and raw materials.

1. Itihāsa-Purāṇa: The Cyclic Fall from Satya Yuga

The Indian tradition understands time as cyclical (Yugas). Amatya's constant invocation of a lost golden age (the Rāmāyaṇa era of King Janaka, Sita, and the Videha kingdom) functions as a Paurāṇic critique of the present Kali Yuga. In "मिथिला महात्म्य" (The Glory of Mithila), he writes:

"स्वर्गक कामना छोडू मैथिल / धन्य-धन्य अछि मिथिला देश।" (Abandon the desire for heaven, O Maithil / Blessed, blessed is Mithila itself).

This is a direct inversion of the colonial/modernist narrative that peripheral regions are "backward." Amatya argues that Mithila was the center of Dharma. The current state of unemployment ("हमरा चाही रोजगार") is not "underdevelopment" but apakṣaya (decay) from a prior state of completeness. The repeated cry "जाग-जाग सुचा मैथिल जाग" (Wake up, true Maithil) is a call

to remember this Paurāṇic identity and break the cycle of tamas (darkness/inertia).

2. Sāmājik Roga (Social Disease): Diagnosing the Body Politic

Classical Indian political thought (Kautilya's Arthaśāstra) often used medical metaphors for the state. Amatya adopts this framework, diagnosing Mithila as afflicted with a Sāmājik Roga (social disease). The symptoms are listed across poems:

Fever: "हमर करेज ठpमे ठिठुरल" (My heart shivers) – "मिथिलाक गित".

Poison: "सगरो पुष्पित अछि विष वेल" (Every flower is a poisonous creeper) – "सगरो पुष्पित अछि विष वेल".

Cancer/Corruption: "भ्रष्टाचारक भीष्म पितामह" (The Bhishma-pitamah of corruption) – "चौरे सभ मूँहजोर भेल अछि".

The poet acts as the Vaidya (physician) who must first name the disease. The cure is not modern medicine (development schemes) but vaiśika śuddhi (purification of conduct) and a return to samatā-mūlaka (equality-based) social relations. This echoes the Nyāya emphasis on cikitsā (therapy) through correct knowledge.

3. Postcolonial Kṣatriya: The Poet as Anti-Colonial Warrior

In Postcolonial theory (Chatterjee), the "political society" of the periphery operates outside the formal structures of civil society. Amatya identifies the modern Panchayati Raj as a failed, colonizing structure that has replaced indigenous Sabhas (assemblies). He positions himself as a Linguistic Kṣatriya (warrior) defending the borders of Śabda (word) against the invading forces of Hindi/English:

"हम मैथली शुद्ध लिखब से / मुदा आब ओ ज्ञान रहल नहि।" (I want to write pure Maithili / But now that knowledge is gone).

The loss of the Tirhuta script and the purity of Maithili is equivalent to the loss of a kingdom. The poet's fight is not literary but military—an anti-colonial struggle against the "deep state" of Hindi-Urdu-English hegemony. The poem "हम मैथल छी" (We are Maithil) is a declaration of sovereignty:

"हम जातिके छोड़ देने छी / अहूँ जातिके छोडू भाय।" (I have left my caste, you leave yours too).

This is a call to form a new jāti—not caste, but Maithil-hood—as a resistant political community. It parallels the Vajjika League's formation of a republican confederacy against the Magadhan empire.

4. Dehej as Upaniṣad (Colonial Transaction)

Amatya's most devastating critique is of dowry (dehej). In "बेटी बापक सन्ताप" (The Lament of a Daughter's Father), he writes:

"दुष्ट देहेजक उपनिवेशमे / हमहूँ छी बेटीकेर बाप।" (In the colony of evil dowry / I too am the father of a daughter).

The use of the word उपनिवेश (colony) is deliberate. Dowry is not a tradition; it is a colonial extraction of wealth from the already poor. It is the internal colony within the family, where the daughter becomes a commodity to be traded, and the father becomes a debtor. This reframes the classical Kanyādān (gift of a daughter) as a Kanyā-vikraya (sale of a daughter). The Shāstra has been inverted, and the poet's lament is the cry of a śūdra father crushed by a system he cannot escape.

Language as Kṣetra (Field of Battle)

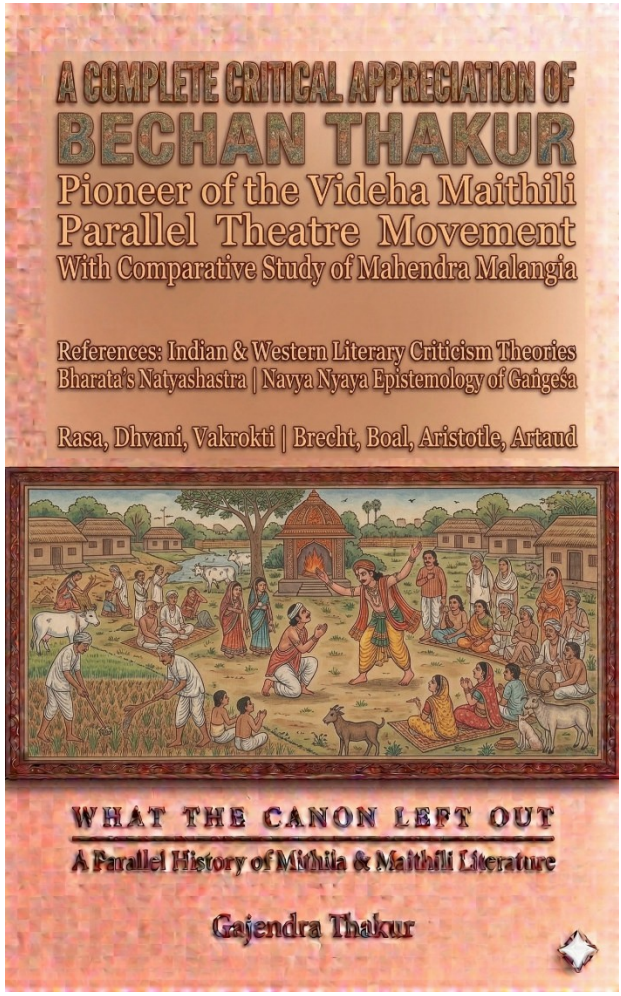
**Prof. Harimohan Jha's linguistic framework show that the loss of language is the loss of kingdom. Language as Kṣetra (Field of Battle)**

Prof. Hari Mohan Jha's work demonstrates that Indian philosophers treated language as a precise tool for analyzing reality. Amatya's lament about the loss of Maithili ("हम मैथली शुद्ध लिखब से / मुदा आब ओ ज्ञान रहल नहि") is not nostalgia but a political diagnosis. When the Tirhuta script and pure vocabulary are lost, the avacchedaka (limiting criteria) for what constitutes 'Maithili' is erased. The postcolonial state, through Hindi/English hegemony, has imposed a vyadhikaraṇa abhāva (non-existence in a different locus)—the word 'Maithili' now exists, but its meaning has been relocated to a museum, not a living community. Amatya's entire anthology is an attempt to restore sāmānādhikaraṇa (co-reference) between the signifier 'Maithil' and the signified 'dignity, land, and language'.

Conclusion: The Itihāsa of Theft

The final poem, "इतिहासक अनुपम पत्रा" (The Unique Page of History), tells a local folk tale of stolen shoes. In the Videha framework, this mundane story becomes allegorical: The modern Maithil has had his "footwear" (dignity, language, land, daughters) stolen while he slept. Amatya's anthology is the Itihāsa (thus indeed it happened) of this theft. He attempts to be the Cāṇakya of this era—not by writing strategy, but by writing Vyatha (suffering) into the historical record. He invokes the Purāṇic duty of the kavi (poet) to bear witness to Dharma and Adharma, hoping that a future Yuga will read this page and finally "Jag" (wake up) to reclaim the lost kingdom of words.

**LESSON 017 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**




# A COMPLETE CRITICAL APPRECIATION OF

# BECHAN THAKUR

*Pioneer of the Videha Maithili Parallel Theatre Movement*

With Comparative Study of Mahendra Malangia

References: Indian & Western Literary Criticism Theories

Bharata's Natyashastra | Navya Nyaya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa

Rasa, Dhvani, Vakrokti | Brecht, Boal, Aristotle, Artaud

# Chapter I: Maithili Theatre, Caste, and the Parallel Movement

## 1.1 The Theatrical Landscape of Mithila

Mithila — the ancient Videha kingdom of Janaka, homeland of Sita, birthplace of Gangesa Upadhyaya's Navya Nyaya philosophy — has sustained a theatrical tradition of extraordinary antiquity. The Natyashastra of Bharatamuni identifies a body of early performance forms rooted in folk practice; the Maithili literary tradition, from Vidyapati's geets performed at court and village alike to the Ankiya Nat tradition of Assam (which draws on Maithili sources), demonstrates the long-standing centrality of performance to the region's cultural life. Medieval Maithili theatre encompassed Sanskrit natya (Vidyapati's Goraksavijaya), folk performance genres (the gamaya nach, jat-jatin dance-theatre, samaichakeva, etc.), and the socio-religious performances embedded in life-cycle rituals.

In the twentieth century, the institutionalisation of Maithili theatre brought with it a significant problem: the 'jativadi' or casteist bias that concentrated theatrical production, direction, and critical authority in the hands of upper-caste (primarily Brahmin-Kayastha) communities. The works selected for staging, the aesthetics valorised, the actors recruited, and the audiences addressed all reflected and reinforced caste hierarchy. This is the context against which the Videha Maithili Parallel Theatre Movement, pioneered by Bechan Thakur from the 1990s onwards, must be understood.

## 1.2 Videha and the Parallel Theatre Movement

The Videha eJournal (www.videha.co.in), founded by Gajendra Thakur and launched in 2008 as the first Maithili fortnightly e-journal (ISSN 2229-547X), constitutes the intellectual hub of the Videha Maithili Literature Movement. Its explicit manifesto — 'Manushimih Samskritam' (Humans First in Culture) — signals its commitment to the democratisation of Maithili

culture, the inclusion of subaltern and non-Brahmin voices, and the resistance to what it terms 'jativadi rangmanch' (casteist theatre).

The Videha Maithili Natya Utsav (2012) — documented in the 230-page anthology Videha Maithili Natya Utsav (ISBN 978-93-80538-66-2, Shruti Prakashan, Delhi, 2012) — was the first major public event of the Videha Parallel Theatre Movement. Its proceedings, which include a landmark interview with Bechan Thakur, an extensive critical essay by Gajendra Thakur on parallel Maithili theatre, documentation of 25 years of stage productions directed by Bechan Thakur, and analyses of both Indian and Western dramatic theory, constitute a major document of contemporary Maithili theatrical history.

Bechan Thakur holds the formal editorial position of 'Sampadak: Natak-Rangmanch-Chalchitra' (Editor, Drama-Theatre-Cinema) of the Videha eJournal — a role that reflects his institutional centrality to the Videha movement. This position is explicitly stated in the Videha Sampadakiya (editorial) data, confirming his status as the primary theatrical authority within the movement.

## 1.3 Gangesa Upadhyaya and the Mithila Epistemological Tradition

Any critical appreciation of Maithili theatre must acknowledge the philosophical tradition within which it operates. Gangesa Upadhyaya (c. 14th century, Mithila) — whose Tattvacintamani ('Thought-Jewel of Reality') founded the Navya Nyaya school of Indian logic and epistemology — provides a critical instrument of enormous power. Gangesa's analysis of the four pramanas (means of valid knowledge) — pratyaksha (perception), anumana (inference), upamana (analogy/comparison), and shabda (verbal testimony) — and his rigorous methodology of definition (lakshana), delimitation (avacchedaka), and verification, constitute a framework uniquely appropriate for the analysis of a theatre movement rooted in Mithila's intellectual soil.

The particular relevance of Navya Nyaya to Bechan Thakur's theatre lies in Gangesa's rejection of false cognition (bhrama) — the misleading appearance of truth. Casteist theatre produces a bhrama: it presents itself as 'Maithili' theatre while representing only a fraction of Maithili society, and it produces the false cognition that Brahminical aesthetics are the aesthetics of Mithila as a whole. Bechan Thakur's parallel theatre is, in Navya Nyaya terms, an exercise in correcting this bhrama — of achieving prama (valid cognition) about Maithili social reality through the pratyaksha of direct theatrical representation of subaltern life.

# Chapter II: Bechan Thakur — Life, Context, and Theatrical Mission

## 2.1 Biographical Profile

Bechan Thakur (बेचन ठाकुर) was born and raised in Chanauraganj (चनौरागंज), Bhaya Jhanjharpur, District Madhubani, Mithila, Bihar — a small semi-urban centre in the heart of the Maithili-speaking belt. His caste background — the Barhi (carpenter) community, identified by the 'Thakur' suffix that marks artisan-service castes in Mithila — places him decisively outside the Brahmin-Kayastha literary establishment that has historically dominated Maithili cultural production. He works as a private tutor (coaching teacher), a livelihood that gives him both direct contact with village youth and the economic independence — however modest — to pursue his theatrical work without institutional or governmental support.

Thakur began writing plays during his college years, initially developing his craft through staging productions at the New Lotus English School campus in Chanauraganj, where annual Saraswati Puja celebrations became the regular venue for theatrical production. The documentation in the Videha Maithili Natya Utsav anthology records his productions systematically from 1995 onwards, providing an extraordinary archive of grassroots theatre practice. By the time of the 2012 Videha Natya Utsav, he had maintained this parallel theatre practice for over 25 years — without any government or institutional support — making him one of the most persistent and committed figures in contemporary Maithili theatre.

In his interview with Munjaji (Manoj Kumar Karna) published in the Videha Maithili Natya Utsav anthology, Thakur explains his theatrical genesis in the following terms: 'When I used to go with family or neighbours to see gamaya nach or natak, I was inspired by them, and day by day my interest in theatre grew, and therefore my plays' narratives always contain the state and situation of society and attempts at their possible resolution.' This formulation — society, situation, resolution — encapsulates Thakur's theatrical mission: the social-realist imperative to represent and address lived social problems.

## 2.2 The Works: A Comprehensive Survey

### *2.2.1 Betik Apaman aa Chhinardevi (Insult of the Daughter and Chhinardevi)*

Published by Shruti Prakashan, New Delhi, 2010 (ISBN 978-93-80538-35-8), this two-play volume contains Thakur's seminal plays Betik Apaman (The Insult/Dishonour of the Daughter) and Chhinardevi. It represents his most explicitly feminist work and constitutes a direct theatrical intervention in the crisis of female foeticide and gender devaluation in Mithila and neighbouring regions.

Betik Apaman confronts the practice of sex-selective abortion driven by the dowry system. The play's author's statement is direct and unambiguous: 'Stri-purush dunya kai neeb chhi. Muda dahejak karane samajme betik hei drishti se dekhau jaait chhai. Falasvarup samadhan hetu lok altraasaundak durupyog ke betik vansh naaash karaik pachhu laagal achhi' (Woman and man are the foundation of the world. But because of the dowry system, the daughter is looked down upon in society. As a result, people are pursuing the destruction of daughters through the misuse of ultrasound technology). The play dramatises this crisis through the household of Deepak Chaudhary, exploring the complex of attitudes within a single family — desire for a daughter versus fear of dowry burden — through a rich cast of village characters.

From the Natyashastra perspective, this play operates within the mode of natyadharmi (theatrical convention) as a vehicle for loka-dharma (social ethics). Bharatamuni's definition of the purpose of natya as providing 'counsel to those who are in distress, rest to those who are weary, and entertainment (to those seeking amusement)' is here adapted to a specifically modern social-reform function. The play employs what Bharatamuni calls 'samanya-abhinaya' (general/common representation) rather than 'lokadharmi-abhinaya' (realistic representation) — the characters are recognisable social types (the well-meaning but confused patriarch, the pragmatic wife, the community elders) rather than realistic individuals.

Applying Navya Nyaya analysis: the play's cognitive object (prameya) is the social practice of female foeticide. The pratyaksha-pramana is the audience's direct perceptual recognition of the situations depicted. The anumana-pramana is the play's inferential structure — from the visible behaviour of characters, the audience infers the structural causes (dowry system, patriarchal values, medical technology misuse). The shabda-pramana is the play's verbal testimony, delivered through dialogue that quotes the actual

slogans, proverbs, and rationalizations used by people who practice or condone female foeticide. The play's dramatic function is to correct the social bhrama that female foeticide is a 'natural' or 'inevitable' response to social conditions.

Chhinardevi, the second play in this volume, deals with superstition (andhavishas) in village society. The author's preface explicitly states the social problem: superstition is endemic in both rural Mithila and in ostensibly 'developed' regions like Haryana. The character of Chhinardevi is almost certainly a woman either accused of being a witch (dain) or herself caught in the web of superstitious practice. The dain tradition — the persecution of women as witches — is a live social problem in Bihar and Jharkhand, and Thakur's engagement with it places his work in dialogue with the long tradition of progressive social theatre that uses the stage as a tool of superstition eradication.

### *2.2.2 Baap Bhel Pitti aa Adhikaar (Father Became a Child and Rights)*

Published by Shruti Prakashan, New Delhi, this two-play volume containing Baap Bhel Pitti and Adhikaar was described in reports of its 2012 staging as a 'Mahan Samajik Maithili Natak' (Great Social Maithili Play). The title Baap Bhel Pitti (Father Became a Child) evokes the problem of parental abandonment and the reversal of the traditional parent-child relationship, a theme directly connected to the breakdown of joint family structures and the crisis of elder care in contemporary rural Mithila.

The theme of Baap Bhel Pitti — parents becoming like children, dependent, helpless, subject to their own children's authority — is a distinctively modern social problem that arises at the intersection of nuclear family formation, rural-urban migration, land disputes, and changing inheritance norms. Its theatrical dramaturgy builds through recognition of a familiar domestic situation toward a climactic confrontation that forces the audience to examine its own assumptions about filial duty (putradharm) and parental authority.

Adhikaar (Rights) addresses the question of legal and civic rights — likely the rights of women, Dalits, or marginalised communities — in a system that formally grants rights but practically denies them. The Natyashastra concept of 'arthasthiti' (the logic of situation) is relevant here: the characters of Adhikaar are caught in a situation where the formal possession of rights and their practical exercise are in contradiction, and the dramatic action moves through the recognition of this contradiction toward its attempted resolution.

### *2.2.3 Bhaat (Encounter/Confrontation)*

Bhaat (72 pages, Shruti Prakashan) is one of Thakur's most ambitious works in terms of scale: the character list runs to over 100 named roles, making it a work of massive communal theatre that requires the participation of an entire village community in its production. The title Bhaat means both 'encounter' and 'confrontation' in Maithili, suggesting a political dramaturgy centred on electoral conflict and the confrontation of power.

The character list, as extracted from the text, includes: political leaders at multiple levels (Gobardhananlal, Rameshwar, Jitendra, Shrilal); election officials (Ramtap as Election Commissioner, Giriraj as Deputy Election Commissioner); security forces (Mansingh, Chansingh); party workers, village elders, and various factional members — a total cast that mirrors the full social complexity of a Bihari village during elections. This is theatre as social panorama: the drama encompasses the entire social field of electoral politics, from the highest election administration to the lowest rural voter.

Bhaat operates within the tradition of political epic theatre. Brechtian analysis is directly applicable: the multiplicity of characters prevents individual psychological identification and encourages the audience's critical observation of the social system as a whole. The election — the ritual of democracy — becomes the theatrical event through which the contradictions of Indian democratic practice (vote-buying, caste mobilisation, official corruption, gangster intimidation) are dramatised. The audience is positioned not as sympathisers with any individual character but as critical analysts of the system.

From the Natyashastra perspective, Bhaat employs multiple prakaras (theatrical modes): it contains heroic elements (Rashtra Prabandhan — governance), comic elements (the absurdity of electoral corruption), and grotesque elements (the violence and intimidation). It violates the classical principle of unity of action in order to achieve a broader epic sweep, functioning more in the tradition of the Itihasas (epics) than the classical Sanskrit rupaka.

### *2.2.4 Biswasghat (Betrayal/Breach of Trust)*

Biswasghat (103 pages, Shruti Prakashan) engages with one of the most painful themes in human social life: the betrayal of trust between those who are close — family members, partners, neighbours, associates. The title, from 'vishwasaghat' (betrayal of faith/trust), immediately signals the moral

register of the play: this is a drama about the destruction of the social fabric of trust that holds communities together.

The opening scene of Biswasghat — extracted from the text — shows Ram Kishun reading a newspaper on his veranda when his elder son Ram Sewak brings him tea. This domestic, intimate opening establishes the register of family trust before it is violated: the play's action will presumably move from this quotidian domestic scene toward a revelation of betrayal within the family structure, centred on a land dispute (the papers concerning land that Lakhan and his wife Lakshmi discuss in the second scene).

Land betrayal — the manipulation or theft of land documents — is one of the most common forms of intra-family conflict in rural Bihar, driven by population pressure, land scarcity, and the legal complexity of inheritance. Biswasghat dramatises this specific social pathology: the betrayal of trust embodied in the falsification or manipulation of land records, which destroys family bonds and community solidarity.

In terms of Rasa theory, Biswasghat's dominant rasa is karuna (pathos/compassion), generated by the audience's empathetic recognition of the suffering caused by betrayal within intimate relationships. Abhinavagupta's analysis of karuna in the Abhinavabharati identifies it as the rasa that arises when the audience perceives the suffering of a person with whom they identify through shared humanity. The domestic setting and recognisable social types of Biswasghat facilitate this identification.

### *2.2.5 Oonch-Neech (High-Low / Caste Hierarchy)*

Oonch-Neech (107 pages, Shruti Prakashan, 2013; ISBN referenced in the text) is Thakur's most directly anti-caste theatrical statement. The title — 'high-low' or 'upper-lower' — simultaneously evokes economic inequality (oonch-neech in the sense of social ups and downs) and caste hierarchy (oonch-jati and neech-jati, high and low castes in the traditional Brahminical ordering). This deliberate semantic ambiguity is itself a theatrical technique: it refuses to separate economic exploitation from caste oppression, insisting on their structural unity.

The play's dramaturgy is grounded in the specific conditions of rural Mithila: the characters Mangal and Marni open the play by discussing the changes between their parents' generation and their own, weaving together observations about the great flood (badi) of 1987 and the earthquake (bhumkam) of 1988 — two actual historical events that devastated large parts of Mithila and displaced or impoverished communities. This temporal

anchoring in specific historical catastrophe distinguishes Thakur's realism from generic social drama: his plays are saturated with the specific historical reality of Mithila's subaltern communities.

Oonch-Neech is Thakur's most direct engagement with what the Videha movement calls 'jativadi rangmanch' — casteist theatre — and its alternative. The play dramatises the lived experience of caste discrimination: the micro-aggressions, the economic exploitation, the denial of dignity that constitute the daily reality of lower-caste communities in Mithila. Its theatrical action moves between the recognition of injustice and the search for dignity, resolution, and resistance.

The application of Augusto Boal's 'Theatre of the Oppressed' framework is most directly relevant to Oonch-Neech. Boal's concept of 'poetics of the oppressed' — the project of making the oppressed the subject rather than the object of theatrical representation — perfectly describes Thakur's project in this play. The characters Mangal and Marni are not objects of upper-caste pity or reform-minded patronage; they are the subjects of the theatrical action, articulating their own understanding of their situation and their own search for dignity.

# Chapter III: Critical Analysis — Dramatic Craft and Theatrical Vision

## 3.1 Thematic Architecture

Across his five major texts archived in the Videha Digital Library, Bechan Thakur develops five interconnected thematic concerns that constitute the architecture of his dramatic vision. First is gender justice — the trilogy of gender-based oppression consisting of female foeticide (Betik Apaman), dowry violence, and the witch-hunting of women (Chhinardevi). Second is intergenerational justice — the rights of parents abandoned by children (Baap Bhel Pitti) and the obligations of the young to the old. Third is caste justice — the direct confrontation with Mithila's caste hierarchy as a lived system of oppression (Oonch-Neech). Fourth is political justice — the corruption and criminalisation of electoral democracy (Bhaat). Fifth is the ethics of trust — the social foundations of community life and their betrayal (Biswasghat).

These five themes are not unrelated: they constitute a unified diagnosis of the social pathologies of contemporary rural Mithila. The oppression of women, the abandonment of the elderly, caste discrimination, electoral corruption, and the betrayal of trust all arise from the same structural source: the breakdown of social solidarity under the combined pressures of economic marginalisation, caste hierarchy, and the corrosive effects of poverty and competition. Thakur's theatre is, in this sense, a systematic social pathology — a theatrical diagnosis of what has gone wrong in Maithili village society.

## 3.2 Bharata's Natyashastra and Bechan Thakur's Practice

The Natyashastra of Bharatamuni (c. 200 BCE–200 CE) is the foundational text of Indian dramaturgy, and the Videha Maithili Natya Utsav anthology contains an extensive comparative analysis of Indian and Western dramatic theory (in Gajendra Thakur's lead essay) that provides the critical framework within which Bechan Thakur's work is evaluated. The Natyashastra's comprehensive account of the elements of theatrical production — rasa (emotional flavour), bhava (emotion), abhinaya (expression/representation), vritti (style), siddhi (theatrical success), and the technical specifications of stage space, music, costume, and movement — provides the institutional backdrop against which Thakur's gamaya (village) theatre can be assessed.

Bharata's theory of the dasarupakas (ten dramatic forms) is relevant to the classification of Thakur's plays. His works do not fit neatly into any single classical category: they share features with the nataka (heroic drama), the prakarana (realistic domestic drama), the vyayoga (action-based drama), and the vithi (street or popular performance). This generic hybridity is not a failure of craft but a deliberate adaptation of classical forms to a modern, village-based, social-realist theatrical context. The Natyashastra itself recognises the legitimacy of regional variation and folk adaptation (lokadharmi), and Thakur's gamaya theatre represents precisely this kind of legitimate regional theatrical development.

The concept of rasa-siddhi (theatrical success in emotional impact) in the Natyashastra is evaluated through the response of the sahridaya (connoisseur-audience). For Thakur's village theatre, the sahridaya is not the cultivated aesthetic connoisseur of classical theory but the village audience itself — people who bring direct experiential knowledge of the social situations depicted. The 'connoisseurship' of Thakur's audience is not aesthetic cultivation but social and experiential recognition: the audience recognises their own lives on stage. This is what the Natyashastra's concept of sadharani-karana (universalisation of emotion) means in Thakur's specific context: the transformation of the audience's own social experience into a shared aesthetic event.

The Natyashastra's chapter on the aharya (costume/visual presentation) is relevant to Thakur's minimalist production aesthetic. Without institutional funding or professional production resources, Thakur's theatre operates with minimal aharya — the costume and visual presentation reflect the actual social reality of village Mithila rather than the elaborate conventions of classical or urban professional theatre. This minimalism is not a limitation but a creative choice: it closes the aesthetic distance between representation and reality, making the theatrical event more immediately present and socially legible for its audience.

## 3.3 The Gamaya Theatre Tradition and its Reinvention

Bechan Thakur's theatre is rooted in the gamaya (village) theatrical tradition of Mithila — the popular performance forms (gamaya nach, jat-jatin, samaichakeva, bidesia, etc.) that have sustained theatrical culture in rural Mithila across generations. The gamaya tradition is characterised by: community participation (the entire village is audience and sometimes cast); festive context (performances are embedded in religious and seasonal festivals,

particularly Saraswati Puja); musical integration (harmonium, dhol, and folk instruments are essential); and social commentary (the gamaya performance has always included satirical and reformist elements).

Thakur reinvents this tradition in several important ways. First, he writes fixed scripts rather than relying on the improvisatory or oral tradition of gamaya performance. Second, he addresses contemporary social issues (female foeticide, electoral corruption) rather than mythological or historical themes. Third, he explicitly theorises the political function of his theatre — in his interview with Munjaji, he articulates the opposition between 'parallel theatre' (samantar rangmanch) and 'casteist theatre' (jativadi rangmanch) in explicit ideological terms. Fourth, he creates documentary records of his productions — cast lists, dates, venues — that constitute a historical archive of rural theatrical practice.

## 3.4 Language, Register, and Social Semiotics

The language of Thakur's plays is Maithili in its gamaya register — the vernacular speech of lower-caste village communities, with its specific phonological features, proverbs, idioms, and expressive patterns. This linguistic choice is itself a political statement: it asserts the theatrical legitimacy of subaltern Maithili speech against the 'literary' Maithili of the Brahmin-Kayastha establishment, which privileges Maithili's Sanskrit-derived lexical register and its connection to the medieval literary tradition.

From a semiotic perspective (following Barthes' analysis of language as ideology), the choice of gamaya Maithili for theatrical dialogue is an act of linguistic valorisation: it declares that the speech of lower-caste communities is not a degraded variant of 'correct' Maithili but a legitimate literary and theatrical language. This valorisation has profound implications for the reception of Thakur's theatre by his primary audience — the lower-caste village communities of Mithila, who hear their own speech on stage, validated as theatrical language.

The Navya Nyaya concept of shabda-pramana (verbal testimony as means of valid knowledge) is relevant here: Thakur's theatre asserts the epistemic validity of gamaya speech as a means of knowing social reality. The testimony of lower-caste characters — their accounts of discrimination, exploitation, and injustice — is presented as valid knowledge (prama) rather than as the distorted or limited perspective of the socially marginalised.

# Chapter IV: Critical Frameworks — Indian and Western Theories Applied

## 4.1 Rasa Theory (Bharatamuni, Abhinavagupta)

The rasa theory identifies eight principal aesthetic emotions (rasas) and their corresponding permanent emotions (sthayi-bhavas). Applied to Thakur's dramatic corpus, the dominant rasas are: karuna (compassion/pathos), arising from the depiction of social suffering — the abandoned parent of Baap Bhel Pitti, the daughter devalued in Betik Apaman, the lower-caste person discriminated against in Oonch-Neech; raudra (fury/righteous anger), arising from the depiction of injustice — electoral corruption in Bhaat, caste oppression in Oonch-Neech; vira (heroism/moral courage), arising from the depiction of resistance to oppression; and bhayanaka (terror), arising from the depiction of social violence, superstition, and the threat of witch-hunting.

Abhinavagupta's analysis of rasanishpatti (the production of rasa in the audience-consciousness) through the process of sadharani-karana (universalisation) is particularly relevant. For Abhinavagupta, the transformation of the personal emotions of characters into universalised aesthetic experiences accessible to the audience requires a specific kind of imaginative participation — the sahridaya's willingness to enter into the emotional world of the drama while maintaining aesthetic distance. Thakur's village theatre achieves this through the mechanism of social recognition: the audience's identification with the characters' situations is not merely imaginative but experiential, grounded in the shared reality of village life.

## 4.2 Dhvani Theory (Anandavardhana) and Theatrical Suggestion

Anandavardhana's theory of dhvani (suggestion/resonance) in the Dhvanyaloka identifies suggested meaning (vyanjana-artha) as the supreme dimension of literary expression. Applied to Thakur's dramaturgy, the concept of dhvani illuminates the way his plays operate on multiple levels of meaning simultaneously. The surface narrative of Oonch-Neech — a domestic scene between Mangal and Marni discussing floods and earthquakes — resonates with deeper suggested meanings: the social 'floods' of caste discrimination, the political 'earthquakes' of structural inequality. The gamaya setting resonates with the entire history of lower-caste theatrical exclusion; each scene of village life suggests the historical depth of Mithila's social contradictions.

The dhvani dimension of Thakur's theatre is also political: the plays say more than they directly state. The titles alone — Oonch-Neech (high-low), Biswasghat (betrayal), Baap Bhel Pitti (father became child) — carry dhvani beyond their literal meanings, suggesting the structural inversions (the high becoming low, trust becoming betrayal, the parent becoming child) that characterise the social world Thakur depicts.

## 4.3 Navya Nyaya Epistemology and Theatrical Cognition

Gangesa Upadhyaya's Navya Nyaya provides a uniquely Mithila-specific critical framework for Bechan Thakur's theatre. Gangesa's central project — the rigorous analysis of the conditions of valid cognition (prama) and the identification and correction of false cognition (bhrama) — translates into the theatrical domain as follows: valid theatrical cognition (natya-prama) arises when the theatre accurately represents social reality through appropriate means; false theatrical cognition (natya-bhrama) arises when theatrical representation distorts, conceals, or misrepresents social reality — as occurs in 'jativadi rangmanch' (casteist theatre) that presents Brahminical perspectives as universal Maithili reality.

The four pramanas map onto distinct dimensions of theatrical production and reception. Pratyaksha (perception) corresponds to the direct sensory experience of theatrical performance — the audience's immediate perceptual engagement with the bodies, voices, movements, and visual imagery of the stage. Anumana (inference) corresponds to the critical and analytical dimension of theatrical reception — the audience's inferential movement from what they see and hear to conclusions about social causes, structural conditions, and systemic injustice. Upamana (analogy/comparison) corresponds to intertextual theatrical experience — the audience's recognition of Thakur's plays in relation to other theatrical experiences, folk narratives, and social stories they know. Shabda (verbal testimony) corresponds to the linguistic dimension of theatrical experience — the authority of theatrical dialogue as a form of valid social testimony.

Gangesa's concept of avacchedakatva (delimitation or qualification) is relevant to the analysis of Thakur's theatrical method. Each of his plays precisely delimits its social domain: Betik Apaman is delimited to the domain of gender and dowry; Bhaat is delimited to the domain of electoral politics; Biswasghat is delimited to the domain of family trust and land. This precise delimitation — the refusal to scatter across too many social problems

simultaneously — gives each play its analytical focus and its theatrical economy.

## 4.4 Brecht, Epic Theatre, and the Political Stage

Bertolt Brecht's development of Epic Theatre in Weimar Germany and its subsequent influence on world theatre provides one of the most productive Western frameworks for analysing Bechan Thakur's work. Brecht's central innovations — the Verfremdungseffekt (alienation effect), the rejection of Aristotelian catharsis, the historicisation of social situations, the use of narrative interruption and direct address to the audience — all find significant parallels in Thakur's theatrical practice, even if through independent development rather than direct influence.

The Brechtian alienation effect is achieved in Thakur's theatre not through the modernist devices of Brecht's Berlin productions (placards, projected titles, direct addresses to the audience) but through the structural effects of political commentary embedded in the dialogue itself. Characters in Bhaat, for example, explicitly analyse the electoral system as a system — they speak about power structures in ways that invite the audience's analytical engagement rather than passive emotional absorption. The massive cast of Bhaat creates an epic social panorama that prevents the audience from identifying with a single protagonist — a structural Brechtian effect achieved through traditional means.

Augusto Boal's Theatre of the Oppressed is even more directly relevant. Boal's distinction between 'Aristotelian' theatre (which makes the protagonist act on behalf of the spectator who is thus rendered passive) and 'oppressed' theatre (which makes the spectator the protagonist) resonates strongly with Thakur's theatrical project. Thakur's village audience is not a passive audience watching professional performers enact social problems — it is a community of active participants who recognise their own lives on stage and are implicitly invited to analyse, discuss, and act upon the social conditions depicted.

## 4.5 Feminist Literary Criticism and Gender Justice

Bechan Thakur's engagement with gender issues — female foeticide in Betik Apaman, witch-hunting in Chhinardevi, gender dynamics in Baap Bhel Pitti and Biswasghat — places him in dialogue with feminist literary and theatrical criticism. From the perspective of Elaine Showalter's 'gynocriticism' and the broader feminist project of recovering and validating women's

experience in literature and theatre, Thakur's work performs an important function: it makes the bodies, voices, and experiences of Maithili women — particularly lower-caste and lower-class women — visible on the theatrical stage.

The feminist analysis of Betik Apaman is particularly significant. The play dramatises what Adrienne Rich called 'compulsory heterosexuality' and the 'institution of motherhood' in their specific Maithili manifestations: the pressure on women to produce male children, the devaluation of female births, and the technological mediation of this patriarchal demand through the misuse of ultrasound technology. The play's theatrical strategy — showing a family in the process of rationalising female foeticide while gradually revealing the horror of this rationalisation — is a feminist theatrical pedagogy: it uses dramatic irony to expose the ideology that normalises the destruction of female life.

The connection between Thakur's anti-casteist and feminist projects is crucial: in Mithila, caste oppression and gender oppression are structurally linked. Lower-caste women face the compounded disadvantages of gender discrimination within their own communities and caste discrimination from upper-caste structures. Thakur's theatre, which represents both the internal gender dynamics of lower-caste households and the external caste pressures upon them, captures this structural intersection — what feminist theorists (following Kimberlé Crenshaw) call 'intersectionality'.

## 4.6 Post-colonial Theory and the Subaltern Stage

The application of post-colonial theory (Frantz Fanon, Edward Said, Gayatri Spivak, Homi Bhabha) to Bechan Thakur's theatre reveals the distinctively post-colonial dimensions of his theatrical project. Thakur's theatre is post-colonial in a double sense: it responds to the colonial marginalisation of vernacular performance traditions, and it resists the neo-colonial hierarchies of post-independence cultural institutions that perpetuate upper-caste dominance in the name of 'classical' culture.

Spivak's canonical question — 'Can the subaltern speak?' — finds a specific theatrical answer in Thakur's work. In the dominant Maithili theatrical establishment (what Thakur and the Videha movement call 'jativadi rangmanch'), the subaltern — the lower-caste, the female, the rural poor — cannot speak or is spoken for by upper-caste mediators who claim to represent 'Maithili culture' as a whole. Thakur's parallel theatre is an institutional response to this structural silencing: it creates a theatrical space in which

subaltern subjects speak for themselves, in their own language, from their own social location, about their own experiences.

## 4.7 Aristotle, Hamartia, and the Tragic Vision

Aristotle's Poetics — with its concepts of mimesis (imitation of action), catharsis (purification of emotions), hamartia (tragic flaw), peripeteia (reversal of fortune), and anagnorisis (recognition/discovery) — provides a classical Western framework for analysing the dramatic structure of Thakur's plays. While Thakur's theatre is not strictly Aristotelian (it does not centre on a single tragic hero; it does not prioritise catharsis over critical engagement), elements of Aristotelian dramatic structure are clearly operative.

The concept of hamartia — the tragic error or flaw that precipitates catastrophe — has a social rather than individual dimension in Thakur's dramaturgy. The 'tragic flaw' in his plays is not a character's individual moral failing but the social structures of caste, patriarchy, and corruption that distort individual choices and produce collective suffering. In Betik Apaman, the 'hamartia' is not Deepak Chaudhary's individual attitude toward daughters but the entire social system of dowry and gender devaluation that shapes and constrains his choices. This socialisation of hamartia is consonant with Brecht's historicisation of individual fate and with Boal's analysis of the social production of oppression.

# Chapter V: Bechan Thakur and Mahendra Malangia — A Comparative Study

## 5.1 Mahendra Malangia: Profile and Achievement

Mahendra Malangia is one of the most celebrated figures in contemporary Maithili literature and theatre. Born in Malangia village, Rahika block, Madhubani district — the same geographical universe as Bechan Thakur — he has been writing and directing plays for over four decades. He is the recipient of the Sahitya Akademi Award 2024 for his Maithili essay collection Prabandh Sangrah, and has been recognised at multiple national and international literary events, including the Kalinga Literary Festival. His Saat Natak (Seven Plays) — analysed by Abhilasha Kumari in the journal Academia — represents his major theatrical achievement.

According to his profile at the Kalinga Literary Festival, 'Mahendra Malangia's contemporary lies in his continual experimentation and innovation within the broader framework of Indian ways of doing theater in constant dialogue with the folk and classical traditions of performing art in India and Nepal.' This formulation — 'Indian ways of doing theater,' 'folk and classical traditions' — places Malangia within a different theatrical framework from Thakur: where Thakur is primarily engaged in social-realist intervention, Malangia is engaged in aesthetic experimentation and tradition-creative dialogue.

The Videha Maithili Natya Utsav anthology — in Gajendra Thakur's lead critical essay — provides a sharp critical assessment of Malangia's work that must be acknowledged in any comparative study. The essay criticises Malangia's treatment of the 'chhutahar' (untouchable) figure in his play Chhutahar Ghail — noting that even decades after writing the play, the 'chhutahar' remains linguistically marked as lower than the 'neech varg' (lower class). The essay also criticises what it calls Malangia's tendency toward 'sanasanekhez sahitya' (sensationalist literature) and his use of Bollywood dialogue. These criticisms, coming from the Videha movement, reflect the ideological distance between Malangia's aesthetic experimentalism and Thakur's committed social realism.

## 5.2 Comparative Analysis: The Parallel Theatre vs. Institutional Theatre Debate

The fundamental difference between Bechan Thakur and Mahendra Malangia is not primarily aesthetic but structural and ideological. Thakur represents what the Videha movement calls 'samantar rangmanch' — parallel theatre, operating outside and in opposition to the caste-dominated institutional theatre establishment. Malangia represents 'sthapita rangmanch' — established theatre, with its institutional recognitions (Sahitya Akademi), its literary festival presences, and its engagement with both the folk and classical traditions on terms that are broadly acceptable to the establishment.

This structural difference produces different aesthetic choices, different audiences, and different theatrical economies. Thakur's theatre is village-based, community-funded (or self-funded), performed on the Saraswati Puja stage of a school compound in Chanauraganj, with a cast of village youth from multiple caste communities. Malangia's theatre is more broadly institutional, with access to professional production resources, literary festival platforms, and national critical recognition. The difference is not one of quality but of position: each operates in a different field of the Maithili theatrical ecosystem.

From the Natyashastra perspective, both Thakur and Malangia can be evaluated through Bharata's concept of 'siddhi' (theatrical success): the question is not which form of theatre is superior in the abstract but which form achieves its specific theatrical aims. Thakur's theatre achieves siddhi when it produces in its village audience the recognition of social injustice and the emotional motivation to address it. Malangia's theatre achieves siddhi when it produces in its literary festival or institutional audience the aesthetic pleasure of skilled theatrical craftsmanship and cultural reflection.

**Comparative Table: Bechan Thakur and Mahendra Malangia**

| Criterion | Bechan Thakur | Mahendra Malangia |
|---|---|---|
| Background | Barhi- carpenter-caste (Thakur) artisan community; Chanauraganj, Madhubani | Brahmin-dominant landed gentry community; Malangia village, Rahika, Madhubani |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| Ideological Stance | Radically anti-casteist; champions inter-caste equality; Dalit/OBC representation; parallel theatre as anti-establishment movement | Draws on classical traditions; folk and Sanskrit aesthetics; broad social canvas; aesthetics over explicit ideology |
| Language Register | Gamaya (village-vernacular) Maithili; oral rhythms of lower-caste communities | Wider register: classical, folk, and standard literary Maithili |
| Theatrical Model | Community-based; self-financed; grassroots; Saraswati Puja stage; non-institutional | Institutional engagements; Sahitya Akademi recognition; all-India literary circuit |
| Natyashastra Relation | Inverts Bharata's Natyashastra assumption of Brahmin authorship; actualises its democratic spirit | Works within Natyashastra framework; integrates folk forms within classical norms |
| Navya Nyaya Application | Text as pratyaksha of caste reality; anumana of structural injustice | Text as sabda-pramana of living tradition; inference of cultural continuity |
| Thematic Core | Female foeticide, dowry, casteism, electoral corruption, betrayal, fraud | Social conflict, cultural identity, folk mythology, generational change |
| Western Parallel | Brecht (Epic Theatre), Augusto Boal (Theatre of the | Chekhov, Ibsen (realistic social |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | Oppressed), Dario Fo | drama) |
| Awards/Recognition | Videha Samman; Natya-Rangmanch editor of Videha eJournal; 25+ years grassroots theatre | Sahitya Akademi Award 2024; Kalinga Literary Festival recognition; Bihar CM felicitation |

## 5.3 Convergences and Shared Ground

Despite their significant differences, Bechan Thakur and Mahendra Malangia share important ground. Both are rooted in the specific cultural geography of Madhubani district; both draw on the gamaya theatrical tradition of Mithila; both are committed to the vitality of the Maithili language as a theatrical medium; and both have contributed to the archive of Maithili theatrical knowledge that the Videha Digital Library makes accessible. Their differences are productive rather than destructive: they represent the dialectical vitality of a living theatrical tradition that can sustain both committed social realism and aesthetic experimentalism within its compass.

The Navya Nyaya framework helps here: the comparison between Thakur and Malangia is not a competition for the prize of 'better Maithili theatre' but an exercise in upamana-pramana (analogical/comparative cognition). Each artist is evaluated within the appropriate cognitive domain — their specific theatrical aims, their specific social locations, their specific aesthetic choices — and the comparison illuminates the structural features of each by contrast with the other. Gangesa's methodology of precise definition and delimitation prevents the false generalisations that arise when socially committed theatre and aesthetic experimentalism are evaluated by each other's criteria.

# Chapter VI: The Videha Parallel Theatre as Cultural Movement

## 6.1 The 2012 Videha Maithili Natya Utsav — A Landmark Event

The First Videha Maithili Natya Utsav (2012) — documented in the Videha-Sadeh 8 anthology — was a watershed event in the history of Maithili theatre. For the first time, the practitioners of grassroots, community-based, parallel Maithili theatre were brought together with theoretical and critical support from the Videha Literary Movement, producing a public event that demonstrated both the vitality of the movement and the sophistication of its theoretical self-understanding.

The anthology records multiple performance groups, playwrights, and directors from across the Maithili-speaking region — from Madhubani to Janakpur (Nepal) — operating in the tradition of community-based, non-casteist theatre. The breadth of this documentation reveals that Bechan Thakur is not an isolated individual but the most prominent figure in a larger movement of grassroots theatrical practice that the Videha project has helped to make visible and give institutional form.

The anthology also records the resistance this movement has generated from the established theatrical order: threats against Umesh Mandal and others from figures connected to the casteist establishment — documented with specific phone numbers and dates — are reproduced in the published record. This institutional conflict is itself theatrical: the parallel theatre movement's challenge to the established order has provoked real-world intimidation that mirrors the conflicts depicted on Thakur's stage. The theatre and the social reality it represents are not separate domains.

## 6.2 Bechan Thakur's Legacy and Future Directions

In his interview, Bechan Thakur is asked about his creative plans. He responds: 'Nothing definitive can be said about future prospects for theatrical and other creative activities, but the parallel theatre will continue. The will is strong. I will do as much as it is possible to do.' This formulation — 'the parallel theatre will continue; the will is strong' — expresses both the personal commitment and the institutional identity of the movement. The parallel theatre is not Thakur's personal project; it is a movement with its own momentum, sustained by a community of practitioners across Mithila.

Thakur's legacy is multi-dimensional. As a playwright, he has created a body of socially committed drama that addresses the most urgent questions of contemporary Mithila society: gender violence, caste oppression, electoral corruption, intergenerational neglect, and the betrayal of community trust. As a director, he has maintained a 25-year tradition of village theatrical production that has given performance opportunities to youth from multiple caste communities in Chanauraganj and the surrounding area. As a theorist, he has contributed through his interview and his practice to the conceptualisation of 'samantar rangmanch' as a distinct theatrical tradition and ideological position. And as the Natak-Rangmanch editor of the Videha eJournal, he has helped to archive, disseminate, and theorise the broader movement of which his own work is the most vital example.

The Navya Nyaya tradition of Mithila — the tradition in which Gangesa Upadhyaya insisted on the precise, rigorous, and honest cognition of reality against false cognitions — finds its theatrical embodiment in Bechan Thakur's parallel theatre. Just as Gangesa corrected the bhrama (false cognitions) of earlier philosophy through systematic analysis and rigorous definition, Thakur corrects the bhramas of casteist culture — the false representation of Brahminical perspectives as universal Maithili reality, the false naturalisation of caste hierarchy, the false normalisation of gender violence — through the theatrical representation of a social reality that has been hidden, marginalised, and suppressed.

## Chapter VII: Synthesis and Conclusions

Bechan Thakur occupies a unique and significant position in the history of contemporary Maithili theatre. He is simultaneously a practitioner (playwright, director, actor-trainer), an institution-builder (the founder of the Videha Parallel Theatre movement's grassroots theatrical tradition), a theorist (articulating the ideology of 'samantar rangmanch' against 'jativadi rangmanch'), and an archivist (maintaining meticulous records of 25 years of village theatrical production). These multiple roles make him not merely a playwright but a figure of theatrical culture in the fullest sense.

The critical frameworks applied in this appreciation have illuminated different dimensions of Thakur's work. The Natyashastra framework reveals his deep roots in the performative traditions of Mithila and his creative adaptation of classical dramatic categories to modern social reality. The Navya Nyaya framework reveals the epistemological seriousness of his theatrical project — the commitment to correcting false social cognitions through the pratyaksha of direct theatrical representation. The Rasa and Dhvani frameworks reveal the aesthetic dimensions of his dramaturgy — the specific emotional registers of his plays and their capacity for multi-layered suggestion. The Western frameworks of Brecht, Boal, feminist criticism, and post-colonial theory reveal his affinities with the global traditions of committed and oppressed-people's theatre, placing his village-based work within an international theatrical conversation.

The comparative study of Bechan Thakur and Mahendra Malangia reveals the productive complexity of the contemporary Maithili theatrical field: two playwrights from the same geographical region, working in the same language, drawing on some of the same folk traditions, but occupying radically different social and ideological positions within the Maithili cultural ecosystem. Their coexistence and their tension illuminate the dynamics of a living literary and theatrical tradition.

The Videha Digital Library's archiving of Bechan Thakur's five major plays — Betik Apaman aa Chhinardevi, Baap Bhel Pitti aa Adhikaar, Bhaat, Biswasghat, and Oonch-Neech — ensures that this remarkable body of grassroots theatrical work is accessible to scholars and practitioners globally, beyond the geographical and institutional limits of Mithila's village culture. This archiving act, combined with the documentation of 25 years of theatrical production in the Videha Maithili Natya Utsav anthology and the critical and theoretical apparatus of the Videha Literary Movement, constitutes one of the

most significant acts of subaltern cultural preservation in contemporary Indian literary history.

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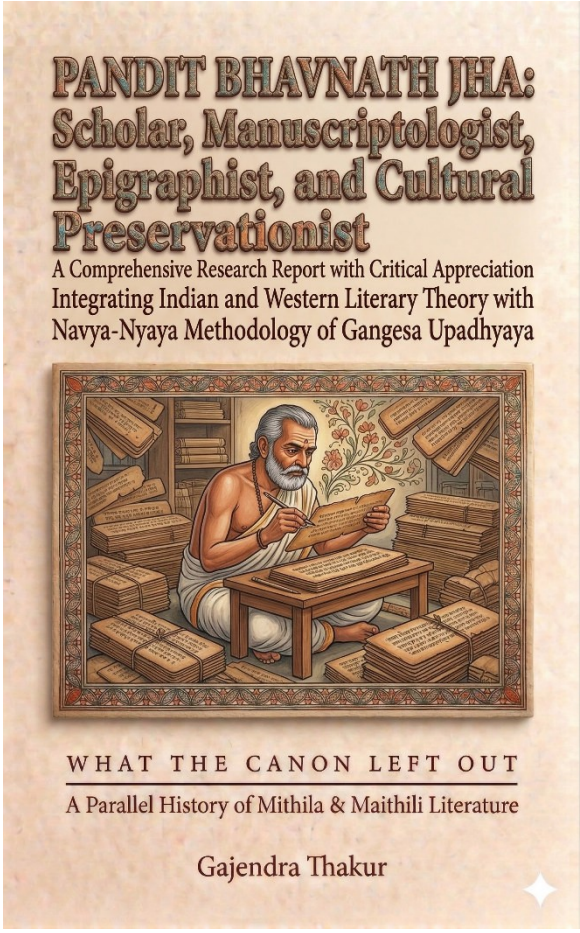
**LESSON 018 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**




# PANDIT BHAVNATH JHA

*Scholar, Manuscriptologist, Epigraphist, and Cultural Preservationist*

*A Comprehensive Research Report with Critical Appreciation*

Integrating Indian and Western Literary Theory with Navya-Nyaya Methodology of Gangesa Upadhyaya

## Abstract

This research report provides a comprehensive critical study of Pandit Bhavnath Jha (born 23 September 1968, Hatadh Rupauli, Madhubani, Bihar), one of the foremost living scholars of Mithila's manuscript and epigraphic traditions. Drawing from Videha e-Journal's special issue No. 428 (15 October 2025, ISBN: 978-93-344-5087-3) — the most extensive single-volume appreciation of Bhavnath Jha published to date — together with biographical material from brahmipublication.com, Mahavir Mandir Patna publications, and academic scholarship on the Agastya Samhita, Buddhacharitam, and related works, this report examines Jha's multidimensional contributions across palaeography, epigraphy, Sanskrit scholarship, editorial practice, Maithili creative writing, and cultural historiography. The report applies a syncretic critical framework: (i) Indian aesthetic theory (Dhvani, Vakrokti, the Sanskritic literary ideal of 'Kantasammita Upadesh'); (ii) Western critical theory including New Historicism, Post-Colonial theory, and the sociology of knowledge; and (iii) the Navya-Nyaya epistemological method of Gangesa Upadhyaya (14th century, Mithila) with its four pramanas — pratyaksha (perception), anumana (inference), upamana (comparison), and shabda (testimony) — applied to evaluate the epistemic foundations of manuscript scholarship and its claims to historical and cultural truth. The report argues that Jha represents a rare confluence of traditional pandit learning and modern scholarly method, embodying what Vijay Deo Jha memorably termed a 'Pandit with MacBook and manuscripts' — a figure who is simultaneously rooted in Mithila's deep knowledge traditions and oriented toward their systematic preservation and dissemination in the digital age.

Contents: 1. Introduction | 2. Biographical Profile | 3. The Videha Special Issue Context | 4. Intellectual Formation and Academic Career | 5. Published Works: An Annotated Survey | 6. Critical Appreciation: Indian Frameworks | 7. Critical Appreciation: Western Frameworks | 8. Critical Appreciation: Navya-Nyaya Methodology | 9. Bhavnath Jha's Literary Works: A Critical Assessment | 10. Sociological and Institutional Dimensions | 11. Reception and Significance | 12. Conclusion | 13. References

# 1. Introduction

## 1.1 The Intellectual Context: Mithila's Knowledge Traditions

Mithila, the ancient region encompassing northern Bihar and southern Nepal's Terai, has for more than two millennia been one of the pre-eminent centres of Sanskrit learning in the Indian subcontinent. The philosophical schools of Nyaya and Vaisesika found their most sophisticated development in Mithila: Gangesa Upadhyaya, the founder of Navya-Nyaya (New Logic), was a Maithil Brahmin from the village of Karion near Darbhanga (14th century CE); Vacaspati Misra, the encyclopaedic philosopher, was also from Mithila; and Udayana, whose theological arguments for the existence of God influenced Gangesa's epistemology, lived in the same region. The grammatical tradition (Vyakarana), which Bhavnath Jha's own father Pt. Amarnath Jha mastered, traces its Maithili lineage through several centuries of distinguished practitioners.

Yet this extraordinary intellectual inheritance has faced severe threats of neglect, physical decay, and institutional indifference. A vast quantity of Sanskrit manuscripts in Tirhuta (Mithilakshar) script — containing texts on grammar, logic, poetics, ritual, history, and science — lies in private collections, temple libraries, and institutional repositories in states of varying preservation. The Bihar Research Society's descriptive catalogue project of the mid-20th century covered only a fraction of the available material before stalling. The National Manuscript Mission (established 2003 by the Ministry of Culture, Government of India) has renewed the effort, but the scale of unedited, uncatalogued material remains enormous. It is into this landscape of urgent need and fragile opportunity that Bhavnath Jha's career has been entirely directed.

## 1.2 The Bhavnath Jha Special Issue: A Cultural Event

Videha e-Journal Issue 428 (15 October 2025), edited by Gajendra Thakur and coordinated by Ashish Anchinhar, represents a landmark in Maithili parallel literary culture: a sustained multi-author assessment of a living scholar whose primary medium is not creative literature but the arcane sciences of palaeography (pandu-lipi vigyan) and epigraphy (shilalekh vigyan). The issue features contributions from seventeen writers including scholars, researchers, journalists, and creative writers — in Maithili, Hindi, and English — addressing different facets of Jha's work. Its publication reflects the Videha movement's democratic expansiveness: the willingness to honour the scholar

who works in the shadows of institutional recognition, serving the knowledge tradition without the rewards that more visible forms of cultural production attract.

Multiple contributors to the issue note that when the announcement was made on 16 August 2025, many readers admitted ignorance of Bhavnath Jha's name — a confession that itself constitutes social data about the institutional marginalization of manuscript scholarship in contemporary Maithili intellectual life. The special issue thus serves a double function: critical appreciation and public introduction, ensuring that a scholar of national and international significance becomes known to the broad Maithili-reading public.

## 2. Biographical Profile

### 2.1 Early Life and Family

Bhavnath Jha was born on 23 September 1968 in the village of Hatadh Rupauli, post-office Hatadh Rupauli, via Jhanjharpur, district Madhubani, Bihar. His father was Pandit Amarnath Jha (02-07-1919 to 18-06-2000) and his mother Yogeshwari Devi. His paternal grandfather was Buddhiinath Jha and grandmother (dai) Durga Devi. He is currently resident at Khas Mahal, Maruti Nagar, Postal Park Road, Patna 800020; his official correspondence address is the Publication Division, Mahavir Mandir, Patna 800001.

The family genealogy is of considerable significance for understanding Bhavnath Jha's intellectual formation. His lineage descends, through the Gangauli line in Mithila, from the philosopher Vacaspati Misra — the same intellectual tradition that produced Gangesa Upadhyaya's predecessor-context — and traces through twenty-one generations of Maithil Brahmin scholars. His more recent ancestor, Kalidasa Jha, came from the Badhyam region and settled in Rupauli around the early 18th century. His great-grandfather Janardana Jha (a prominent figure, styled 'Prasiddha Janardana') had three sons: Buddhinath Jha, Bhagiratha Jha, and Ridhinath Jha.

Bhavnath Jha's father Pandit Amarnath Jha was a distinguished Sanskrit grammarian, a Jyotisha (astrology) specialist, and a traditional palaeographer. He had studied under his maternal uncle, the great grammarian Pandit Dinabandhu Jha, and served as a teacher at Sanskrit institutions in Ishapur and elsewhere, retiring in 1987 as Principal of Tejdhari Nandan Sanskrit High

School. His specialized abilities — including the preparation of palm leaves for traditional writing, making ink (masi) from traditional recipes, and producing paper from bamboo (bang) — were the direct intellectual inheritance that Bhavnath Jha absorbed and extended. Vijay Deo Jha writes that the father was a 'world's wonder in traditional grammarian expertise' and that the younger Jha became his 'worthy disciple in palaeography.'

## 2.2 Education

Bhavnath Jha completed his secondary schooling at Lakshmishwar Academy, Sarisab-Pahi, where he encountered the celebrated Maithili fiction writer Manmohan Jha, Pandit Lilakara Jha, Jitendra Narayan Jha, and Jivanath Misra as teachers — educators who instilled a love of literary composition. He pursued his undergraduate studies in History, English, and Sanskrit, completing his B.A. with Honours in Sanskrit from Maharaj Lakshmishwar Singh College, Sarisab, in 1988-89. He then completed his M.A. (Sanskrit) from Lalit Narayan Mithila University, Darbhanga, in 1992 — a course involving eminent scholars including Pandit Triloknath Jha, Pandit Shaktidhara Jha, and Professor Shrivardhana Thakur. He qualified the UGC National Eligibility Test in June 1993. He subsequently obtained the Sahityacharya degree from Kameshwar Singh Darbhanga Sanskrit University, Darbhanga, in 1995.

## 2.3 Professional Career

Bhavnath Jha's professional career has been entirely oriented toward the service of Sanskrit scholarship and manuscript preservation. From 1995 to 1998 he taught at Saraswati Shishu Mandir, Aunta (Mokama). From 1998 to 2003 he served as a teacher at Ajit Kumar Mehta Sanskrit Shikshan Sansthan, Ladaura, Kalyanapur, Samastipur — a National Sanskrit Sansthan-affiliated institution — while simultaneously undertaking the transliteration of eighteen manuscripts for Kameshwar Singh Darbhanga Sanskrit University under the direction of Pandit Shashinath Jha. Since 2003, he has served as Publication Officer (Prakashan Padadhikari) at Mahavir Mandir, Patna, under Acharya Kishore Kunal — a position that has given him institutional support for his scholarly work. He is currently also the editor of Dharmayan, the flagship periodical of Mahavir Mandir Trust, a journal of culture, religion, and scholarly inquiry.

### 2.4 Family

Bhavnath Jha married Kumud Jha, daughter of the late Suresh Jha of Maibi village (Darihar descent). They have two sons and two daughters: Rakesh Kumar (M.A. in Sculpture from Visva-Bharati, Shantiniketan, currently serving as District Art and Culture Officer in West Champaran under Bihar Government); Arati Mishra (M.A. Sanskrit, Lalit Narayan Mithila University, married to Neeraj Mishra in Darbhanga); Alka Jha (B.A. LL.B., Kolkata University, practising as advocate in Bihar courts, married to Savyasachi Abhijit Prasiddhavagisha, son of Dr. Vinayananda Jha); and Abhichandra Jha (student of Fashion Technology at NIFT, Patna). The family is notable for its maintenance of the traditional scholarly ethos alongside modern professional education.

## 3. The Videha Special Issue: Structure and Significance

Videha Issue 428 is structured around nineteen separate contributions, preceded by an editorial introduction by Gajendra Thakur, and organised in roughly thematic groupings moving from general appreciation and biographical overview to specific scholarly analyses of Jha's individual works. The contributors span scholars of different generations and disciplines, creating a layered portrait of the subject.

The issue represents the mature phase of Videha's 'Living Writer Special Issue' programme — a practice pioneered since 2015 of publishing appreciative-critical volumes on living scholars, writers, and cultural workers while they can still read and respond. The programme was itself a methodological innovation in Maithili literary culture, where the tradition had been to publish tributes only posthumously. As Gajendra Thakur's editorial notes, Bhavnath Jha joins a distinguished lineage of Videha honourees including Arwind Thakur (2015), Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil' (2015), Kedaranath Choudhary (2022), Laxman Jha 'Sagar' (2023), and others.

The special issue includes Dr. Kailash Kumar Mishra's essay calling Jha 'a living human heritage of Mithila' (Mithilak jivit manav dharohar), Vijay Deo Jha's English essay 'Pandit with MacBook and Manuscripts', Dr. Vinayananda Jha's annotated list of books edited from Jha's manuscripts, Bhairav Lal Das's essay on Jha's research vision, Munnaji's essay on Jha's contribution to

establishing the canonical status of the Bihani Katha (ultra-short story) form, Kalpana Jha's extended interview, Dr. Sri Krishna 'Jugnu's essay on the Agastya Samhita (translated from Hindi by Ashish Anchinhar), and Ashish Anchinhar's concluding essay on Jha's significance for Indian knowledge traditions.

# 4. Intellectual Formation and Scholarly Method

## 4.1 The Traditional-Modern Synthesis

Bhavnath Jha's intellectual formation is distinguished by a rare synthesis that Dr. Kailash Kumar Mishra identifies as its central characteristic: deep rootedness in the traditional pandit learning of Mithila — acquired through family inheritance and formal Sanskrit education — combined with full engagement with modern technologies, critical methodologies, and institutional structures of knowledge dissemination. Vijay Deo Jha's memorable portrait of the 'Pandit with MacBook and manuscripts' captures this precisely: here is a scholar surrounded by palm-leaf manuscripts and paper folios, but working on a laptop, using digital databases, contributing to the National Manuscript Mission's digitization programme, and corresponding with scholars in Rajasthan, Assam, and Nepal via WhatsApp and email.

This synthesis is not merely instrumental — it is intellectually programmatic. Jha's interview with Kalpana Jha is strikingly direct on this point: he argues that the failure of Maithili University professors to engage with manuscript and epigraphic science is a 'disgrace' (vipambana) for the tradition, and that the academic world has confined itself to a 'frame' (frame) of creative literature and commentary while ignoring the primary sources that undergird all authentic historical and cultural knowledge. His advocacy for Tirhuta (Mithilakshar) script over Devanagari — both for practical use and for manuscript study — is not mere sentiment but is grounded in his technical understanding of the scripts' different abilities to represent the phonological system of classical Maithili and Sanskrit.

## 4.2 The Shilalekh and Pandu-Lipi Sciences

The two disciplines that define Bhavnath Jha's scholarly identity are pandu-lipi vigyan (palaeography/manuscriptology) and shilalekh vigyan (epigraphy). In

his interview he articulates the requirements of each with the precision of a practitioner. Reading manuscripts requires: (a) full knowledge of the script, including its regional variant forms; (b) approximately 75% linguistic competence in the relevant language; and (c) at least 50% familiarity with the subject matter of the text — or at minimum, knowledge of the specialist vocabulary of that field. Editing manuscripts requires complete subject expertise. Reading inscriptions requires all three competences plus knowledge of the historical context of the region in which the inscription was found.

His field method for epigraphic work demonstrates empirical rigour: the best technique for preserving inscriptions is ink-stamping (stamp-making), which involves wetting stone, pressing paper of the same shape onto the surface, applying a cloth pad with carbon powder, and tapping out each letter. The result, once dried, preserves the letter forms with complete fidelity. Photography has become common but can introduce ambiguity in difficult cases. Prior to any reading, inscription surfaces must be cleaned; chalk powder applied to the carved portions clarifies letter forms before photography.

## 4.3 The Agastya Samhita Achievement

Perhaps the most dramatically illustrative of Bhavnath Jha's scholarly method is his edition and translation of the Agastya Samhita — a Sanskrit Vaishnava Agama text on the worship of Ram. The scholar Dr. Sri Krishna 'Jugnu' of Rajasthan, an antiquarian who had spent thirty years searching for the authentic text of this work, provides a vivid account in the special issue (translated from Hindi by Ashish Anchinhar) of how Bhavnath Jha resolved a debate that had occupied scholars for three decades. Working from multiple manuscript sources, Jha demonstrated: (a) that the account of Ramananda and his twelve disciples in circulating versions of the Agastya Samhita is an interpolation added no earlier than 1903; (b) that the original text has only 32 chapters, not the expanded version with additional sections; and (c) that the Uttara Khanda (additional section), which had been cited by some scholars as primary evidence for Ramananda's biography, is spurious. Dr. Jugnu writes that Jha's work resolved his three-decade scholarly anxiety and calls it a 'bhurisrama grantha' — a work of immense labour.

# 5. Published Works: An Annotated Survey

## 5.1 Original Creative and Scholarly Works

Bhavnath Jha's original published works include: (1) Ghuri Aau Kamala (Come Back, Kamala — a Maithili long story/dirgha katha, 2000), his first published Maithili fiction; (2) Bhrunapanchasika (a Sanskrit poem in 50 verses on female foeticide, published by Mahavir Mandir, Patna, 2013) — his most celebrated literary work, discussed below; and (3) Davabhagnah (a Sanskrit novel, forthcoming). His unpublished Maithili novel Gahabar Ke Batpar (On the Path to the Sangarama) is set against a Buddhist monastic background of ancient Mithila and deals with religious hypocrisy and moral corruption. He has also written numerous Bihani Kathas (ultra-short stories), published across Maithili journals and collected in Videha-Sadeh 5.

## 5.2 Translations

(1) Buddhacharitam (Sanskrit verse translation, Mahavir Mandir, 2013): The Buddhacharitam is Ashvaghosa's celebrated Sanskrit Buddhist epic of the 2nd century CE. The surviving Sanskrit text is incomplete — only the first thirteen and a half cantos (out of twenty-eight) survive in Sanskrit, while later cantos survive only in Tibetan and Chinese translations. Bhavnath Jha's extraordinary achievement was to re-render these lost cantos from their Tibetan and Chinese translations back into Sanskrit verses that faithfully reproduce Ashvaghosa's style and vocabulary. This is among the most technically demanding forms of Sanskrit scholarly work — a double translation through two non-Sanskrit intermediaries — and it establishes Jha's command of classical Sanskrit poetics at the highest level. The Academia.edu paper based on this work calls the Buddhacharitam 'comparable to Ramayana in Hindu literature' and emphasizes the precision of Jha's stylistic reconstruction.

(2) Kadomke Nishan (Hindi verse translation of Maithili poetry by Dr. Dhirendra Narayan Singh, 2021). (3) Agastya Samhita (Sanskrit Agamic text edition and Hindi translation, Mahavir Mandir, 2009).

## 5.3 Edited Works (Selection of Major Items)

Bhavnath Jha's editorial production is extraordinary in its range, volume, and technical difficulty. The full list in the special issue's biographical profile contains 29 items; below are the most significant. Yaksha Samagamam (Sanskrit commentary and Hindi translation of M.M. Parmeshwar Jha's

Sanskrit poem, 1996). Rudraarchana Paddhati (Vedic Rudra text collection, co-edited, Hindi translation, Mahavir Mandir, 2004). Ramarchana Paddhati (Ramananda's Ramarchana text, co-edited, Hindi translation, 2004). Durga Saptashati (commentary based on ancient Sanskrit glosses, Mahavir Mandir, 2005 — 5 editions through 2017). Agastya Samhita (from manuscript, 2009). Mithila Tirtha Prakash (Sanskrit, Mithila Shodh Sansthan, 2017). Maithili Bhakti Prakash (Maithili ancient songs, 2017). Sampurana Bhu-Parikramana of Mahakavi Vidyapati (restoration and English translation with Vijay Deo Jha, Esammad publications, 2025). Sabha Kaumudi and Sabha Vinoda (both for National Manuscript Mission, 2025).

He has written forewords (bhumika-lekhan) for six books between 2010 and 2022. He has contributed 32 research articles to major journals between 1980 and 2024, covering topics including: Tirhuta script presence in Madhubani district; historical evidence from Mithila inscriptions; ancient marriage traditions (based on an account by Maharaja Rameshwar Singh of Darbhanga Raj); the Panji tradition and its historical significance; the cultural topography of Mithila; Buddhist history of the region; and the origin of Janaki's (Sita's) birthplace in Mithila.

### 5.4 Manuscript Catalogue Work

Alongside his editorial and literary work, Jha has produced three major manuscript catalogue projects: organization and catalogue preparation of the private disordered manuscript collection of Pandit Brahmananda Jha in Sirasiya, Sahara (1998); the Descriptive Catalogue of Sanskrit Manuscripts in Bihar Research Society and Patna Museum (2014, published); and organization of 250 manuscripts in the private collection of Smt. Priyamvada Iyer, Dehradun (2015). These represent the infrastructure of scholarly preservation — enabling future research by making collections findable and describable.

## 6. Critical Appreciation: Indian Literary and Philosophical Frameworks

### 6.1 The Kantasammita Upadesh Ideal

The deepest Indian critical framework for Bhavnath Jha's work is provided by the literary-philosophical concept he himself articulates in his interview with

Kalpana Jha: 'Kantasammita Upadesh' — the ideal of instruction offered in the manner of a beloved, sweetly and with willingness to be heard. This concept, drawn from Sanskrit poetics (Kavyashastra), defines literature's social function not as a mirror held to society (samaj ka darpan) but as a guide and direction-setter for society (samaj ka disha-nirdeshak). Jha explicitly distinguishes his literary philosophy from what he calls the 'progressivist domination' (pratisheel-vad ki dadagiri) in contemporary Maithili literature, which he sees as reducing literary art to social documentation, to the repetition of darkness without offering the light of a single lamp.

This is not conservatism but epistemological idealism: Jha argues that literature should present an ideal (adarsha) while remaining rooted in reality, and that the Kantasammita Upadesh mode — aesthetic, appealing, sweetly instructive — is the classical Indian answer to the question of how truth can be communicated without alienating the audience. His Sanskrit poem Bhrunapanchasika exemplifies this ideal: addressing female foeticide in fifty Sanskrit verses, it deploys the aesthetic resources of classical Sanskrit poetry (imagery, metre, rasa theory) to make the argument against a social evil that destroys the foundation of human civilization. Dr. Abha Jha's analysis of this text in the special issue notes its fusion of social critique and literary sophistication — a model of socially engaged Sanskrit composition.

## 6.2 Rasa Theory and the Bhrunapanchasika

Applied to Bhrunapanchasika, classical Rasa theory (Bharatamuni, Abhinavagupta) reveals a sophisticated deployment of multiple rasas in service of a single social argument. The dominant rasa is karuna (compassion/pathos) — the grief of the unborn, the horror of the act — but this is contextualised by vira (heroic determination to oppose), and given its effectiveness through shanta (the aesthetic peace of resolution that classical theory identifies as the foundation and synthesis of all rasas). Abhinavagupta's principle of sadharanikarana (universalization) — the literary mechanism by which particular emotion becomes universal aesthetic experience — is fully operative: the fifty verses move from the individual case to the social general to the philosophical universal (the sanctity of life as the highest dharmic value).

The choice of Sanskrit as the vehicle for this message is itself a Rasa-theoretic decision: Sanskrit carries the cultural authority of the shastra tradition, making the argument available to those for whom that tradition is normative, while the poetic form makes it accessible to those who are moved by beauty. This is Kantasammita Upadesh in its purest form.

## 6.3 Dhvani Theory and the Buddhacharitam Restoration

Anandavardhana's Dhvani theory argues that the highest poetry generates meaning not through direct statement (vacyartha) but through resonant suggestion (dhvanipurna vyanjana) — a tertiary level of signification that exceeds both the literal and the figurative. Applied to Bhavnath Jha's restoration of the Buddhacharitam's lost cantos, Dhvani theory illuminates the hermeneutic challenge he faced: how does one detect Ashvaghosa's dhvani — the resonant suggestions embedded in his poetic choices — well enough to reproduce them in a reconstruction from secondary translations? The answer, visible in the text, is through mastery of Ashvaghosa's kavya-dharma — his characteristic deployment of simile, compound structure, metre, and word-choice — which leaves traces detectable even in translation.

The restoration is thus a form of dhvani archaeology: working backwards from the translated surface of the text to reconstruct the original dhvanic structure. This is the most demanding application of Dhvani theory conceivable — not the reader's interpretation of an existing text but the scholar's creative reconstruction of a vanished original through its translation-shadows.

## 6.4 Vakrokti and Bhavnath Jha's Literary Voice

In his Maithili creative writing, particularly the Bihani Kathas (ultra-short stories) and the long story Ghuri Aau Kamala, Bhavnath Jha employs what Kuntaka's Vakroktijivita would call 'compositional vakrokti' — the oblique, indirect mode of literary address that charges the literal surface with multiple layers of significance. The reviewer Ramesh, writing in the special issue, notes that Ghuri Aau Kamala demonstrates a persistent habit from Jha's manuscript work: the constant search for the underlying manuscript truth (pandu-lipi ki sanch) in every social situation. The palaeographer's habit of looking beneath the surface for the authentic text becomes, in the fiction, a narrative stance that refuses easy interpretation and demands active readerly engagement — the perfect practical expression of Vakrokti's literary principle.

# 7. Critical Appreciation: Western Critical Frameworks

## 7.1 New Historicism and the Politics of Knowledge

Stephen Greenblatt's New Historicism and the broader cultural materialist tradition argue that cultural texts and practices are always embedded in networks of power, that knowledge is never neutral, and that the recovery of marginalized voices and suppressed traditions is a politically significant act. This framework illuminates Bhavnath Jha's work with particular force. The manuscript tradition of Mithila represents exactly the kind of cultural knowledge that New Historicists would identify as suppressed by the dominant narratives of both colonial scholarship (which privileged certain Sanskrit traditions over others) and post-colonial nationalist historiography (which tended to canonize accessible printed texts over archival manuscript materials).

Bhavnath Jha's career can be read as a sustained counter-hegemonic project in New Historicist terms: the recovery and reactivation of suppressed knowledge (the unpublished Sanskrit manuscripts of Mithila), the correction of dominant historical narratives (his work on the Agastya Samhita challenging a century of received opinion), and the articulation of an alternative historiography of Mithila that foregrounds the region's contributions to Indian intellectual culture in ways that standard textbook histories do not.

## 7.2 Post-Colonial Theory: The Native Intellectual and Cultural Recovery

Frantz Fanon's analysis of the 'native intellectual' — the colonial-educated intellectual who turns from European models to reclaim and reconstitute indigenous cultural heritage — resonates strongly with Bhavnath Jha's trajectory, though the colonial dynamic in his case is more complex: it is not Western colonialism alone but also the internal marginalization of Mithila within the Indian academic establishment, and the dominance of Devanagari/Hindi cultural institutions over the Tirhuta/Maithili tradition, that constitute the oppressive structure against which his work is directed.

Gayatri Spivak's question 'Can the Subaltern Speak?' is directly pertinent to the manuscripts themselves: these silent documents, written in a script (Tirhuta) that most contemporary Maithili-speakers cannot read, representing a knowledge tradition that most contemporary scholars cannot access, are the ultimate literary subalterns. Bhavnath Jha's work is literally the project of

giving voice to these texts — and in doing so, he operates as both translator and advocate, performing precisely the function that post-colonial theory identifies as the central task of the committed intellectual.

## 7.3 The Sociology of Knowledge: Bourdieu's Cultural Capital

Pierre Bourdieu's analysis of cultural capital — the non-economic resources (knowledge, skills, credentials, social networks) that confer status and power in cultural fields — provides a useful framework for understanding both Bhavnath Jha's position and the challenges he describes. The special issue repeatedly addresses the question of why Maithili University professors have not engaged with manuscript and epigraphic science. Jha's frank answer — that they are confined to a 'frame' of commentary and creative writing, that their cultural capital is invested in the established fields of Maithili literary studies, and that the acquisition of palaeographic competence requires a kind of capital investment (years of training, exposure to traditional scholars) that the academic system does not reward — is essentially a Bourdieuian analysis of a field-specific capital failure.

Jha himself occupies an unusual position in Bourdieu's terms: he has high specialized cultural capital (palaeographic and epigraphic expertise) that is poorly converted into the currency of the academic field (university positions, Sahitya Akademi recognition), while operating from a non-academic institutional base (Mahavir Mandir) that gives him both freedom and the financial means to pursue his work without standard academic incentive structures.

## 7.4 New Criticism: The Text as Autonomous Artifact

The New Critical tradition — Cleanth Brooks, W.K. Wimsatt, Monroe Beardsley — insists on the autonomy of the literary text, its unity, its resistance to reduction to biography or social context. Applied to Bhrunapanchasika, this methodology reveals the formal excellence that critics have noticed: the fifty verses form a tightly organized argument-structure (employing the Sanskrit rhetorical mode of arthantaranyasa — general statement supported by illustration) that moves from historical and mythological precedents through philosophical argument to social application, with poetic unity maintained throughout by the consistent imagery of life as the highest value, and the metaphor of the daughter as the foundation of all human civilization.

# 8. Critical Appreciation: Navya-Nyaya Methodology of Gangesa Upadhyaya

## 8.1 The Geographical and Intellectual Connection

It is not merely convenient but historically profound that the Navya-Nyaya school of Gangesa Upadhyaya (14th century, Mithila) should provide the evaluative framework for this report on a 20th-21st century Maithil scholar. Gangesa was himself a product of the same region, the same intellectual culture, and the same tradition of rigorous text-based inquiry that Bhavnath Jha serves and extends. The Tattvachintamani, Gangesa's founding text of the New Logic, was written precisely in the tradition that Bhavnath Jha works to preserve: the Sanskrit pandit tradition of Mithila. And the Navya-Nyaya's central concern — the rigorous evaluation of knowledge-claims — is directly applicable to Bhavnath Jha's scholarly enterprise, which is fundamentally a practice of establishing what can and cannot be known about the past from the available manuscript and epigraphic evidence.

As Wikipedia (Navya-Nyaya article) notes, Navya-Nyaya 'developed a sophisticated language and conceptual scheme that allowed it to raise, analyze, and solve problems in logic and epistemology. It involves naming each object to be analyzed, identifying a distinguishing characteristic for the named object, and verifying the appropriateness of the defining characteristic using pramanas.' This is precisely the structure of Bhavnath Jha's manuscript scholarship: name the text (title, author, date), identify its distinguishing characteristics (physical description, script, language, subject), and verify all claims through the four pramanas.

## 8.2 Pratyaksha (Perception) — Direct Manuscript Evidence

Gangesa's analysis of pratyaksha (direct sensory perception) as the most immediate and foundational pramana corresponds in manuscript scholarship to the direct, physical examination of the manuscript or inscription itself. Bhavnath Jha's field methodology — examining manuscripts in private collections (such as his 1998 work cataloguing Pt. Brahmananda Jha's disordered collection in Sirasiya), travelling to Dehradun to organize the Priyamvada Iyer collection, attending manuscripts on-site rather than working from photographs or descriptions — is fundamentally a pratyaksha-oriented epistemology: the primary evidence is what is directly seen and touched.

His interview answers on inscription-reading methodology embody this pratyaksha discipline: clean the surface, apply chalk, use stamping to preserve the letter forms, photograph the result — a systematic procedure for maximizing the reliability of direct perceptual evidence. Gangesa's refinement of the pratyaksha concept to include both external (bahya) and internal (manasa) perception is relevant here too: the scholar's trained visual recognition of scripts and their historical variants is a form of what Gangesa calls 'skilled perception' (alochana-jnana) — perception shaped by acquired competence that exceeds naive sensory registration.

## 8.3 Anumana (Inference) — Reconstructing the Lost

The Navya-Nyaya's theory of anumana (inferential knowledge) based on vyapti (invariable concomitance between a sign/hetu and its probandum/sadhya) is the epistemological foundation of all manuscript restoration work. When Bhavnath Jha restored the lost cantos of the Buddhacharitam from Tibetan and Chinese translations, he employed a sophisticated anumana: from the observed stylistic features (hetu) of the surviving Sanskrit cantos (repeated simile patterns, characteristic compound structures, metrical choices), he inferred (sadhya) the Sanskrit original that must have underlain the available translations — establishing the vyapti (invariable concomitance) between Ashvaghosa's stylistic identity and those features that could be detected across linguistic transformations.

Similarly, his demonstration that the Agastya Samhita's account of Ramananda is an interpolation is a classic anumana argument: the hetu (the textual evidence that Acharya Hemadri cited this text in the 1260-70s) provides inference to the sadhya (the original text predates Ramananda); and the vyapti (a text cannot contain biographical accounts of figures not yet born when the text was already being cited) provides the logical warrant for the conclusion. This is Navya-Nyaya inference applied to textual scholarship with full methodological rigour.

## 8.4 Upamana (Comparison) — Inter-Manuscript Verification

Gangesa's analysis of upamana (knowledge by comparison and analogy) is particularly relevant to the comparative manuscript work that Bhavnath Jha performs when establishing critical texts. The edition of the Agastya Samhita, for instance, required comparing multiple manuscript traditions — the 1898 Ayodhya edition, the manuscript obtained through Gunjan's help, and possibly others — to establish what Navya-Nyaya would call the 'vyavritta' (the distinguishing feature) of the authentic text against its interpolations.

This comparative method also underlies his position on the Tirhuta script: comparing Tirhuta with Devanagari, he argues that Tirhuta's ability to represent the full phonological system of Sanskrit and Maithili (including the 'Varnaratnakar' title that Devanagari cannot properly write) makes it the epistemically superior vehicle for Maithili textual culture. The comparison is not aesthetic preference but an argument from upamana about the relative truth-preserving capacities of the two scripts.

## 8.5 Shabda (Testimony) — The Authority of the Text Tradition

Gangesa's analysis of shabda (verbal testimony) as a pramana — valid knowledge derived from reliable utterance — is the most directly applicable to manuscript scholarship. The central epistemological question of Bhavnath Jha's field is: which manuscripts constitute reliable testimony about the past? His answer draws on all four pramanas: direct examination (pratyaksha) of physical characteristics (age, script, paper/palm-leaf type); inference (anumana) from internal evidence (dates, cross-references, historical allusions); comparison (upamana) with known authentic manuscripts; and finally the authority (shabda) of the scholarly tradition that has preserved and transmitted the texts.

Gangesa's crucial refinement that shabda is valid only when both the speaker's reliability (vaktr-vishvasa) and the utterance's well-formedness (shabda-tatparya) are established corresponds exactly to Bhavnath Jha's criteria for manuscript authenticity: the reliability of the scribe (traditional, professional, or commercial — each category having different reliability profiles as Jha explains) and the internal coherence and authenticity of the text itself. The Navya-Nyaya framework thus provides not merely a metaphor for manuscript scholarship but its actual epistemological structure.

## 8.6 Gangesa's Paratahpramanya and the 'Interpolation Problem'

Gangesa's theory of paratahpramanya ('extrinsic validity') — the position that while cognitions are automatically presumed valid, their validation as genuine knowledge requires a separate process — has a direct counterpart in Bhavnath Jha's treatment of textual interpolations. The tradition of 'prakshepa' (textual interpolation) is well-known in Sanskrit manuscript history: later scribes, commentators, or interest groups added material to existing texts, and these additions circulated as part of the 'authentic' text for centuries. Bhavnath Jha's detection and isolation of the Agastya Samhita interpolation is precisely an exercise in paratahpramanya — refusing the presumptive validity of the received text and demanding external validation through multi-manuscript

comparison, historical cross-reference, and stylistic analysis. This is Gangesa's epistemological rigour applied to the specific challenges of the Sanskrit textual tradition in which Gangesa himself was embedded.

# 9. Bhavnath Jha's Literary Works: A Critical Assessment

## 9.1 Bhrunapanchasika: Sanskrit Activism

The Bhrunapanchasika is Bhavnath Jha's most acclaimed literary creation — fifty Sanskrit verses on female foeticide, published by Mahavir Mandir, Patna, in 2013. Dr. Abha Jha's essay in the special issue provides the most detailed analysis, noting that it combines social criticism with classical Sanskrit aesthetics in a manner that demonstrates Jha's command of both the kavya tradition and contemporary ethical discourse. The poem's title itself signals its literary sophistication: Bhrunapanchasika (The Fifty Verses on the Foetus) is a formal Sanskrit compound that alludes to the classical genre of panchasika (fifty-verse) compositions (like the famous Amaru-Shataka).

The poem's social function — arguing against female foeticide through the medium of Sanskrit verse — represents a deliberate choice of literary register. Sanskrit, as the language of the shastra tradition, carries a normative authority in the communities where the practice of female foeticide is most entrenched. By deploying Sanskrit poetics against this practice, Jha attempts to use the tradition's own cultural authority to reform the tradition's darkest social pathologies. This is a literary-political strategy of considerable sophistication, and it exemplifies the Kantasammita Upadesh ideal that Jha articulates as his literary philosophy.

## 9.2 The Bihani Kathas and Gahabar Ke Bat par

Munnaji's essay in the special issue focuses on Bhavnath Jha's contribution to establishing the canonical status (shastriya paksh ka nirdharan) of the Bihani Katha — the Maithili ultra-short story, comparable to the flash fiction or micro-fiction of Western literary culture, but with specific Maithili formal traditions. Jha's theoretical articulation of what distinguishes a Bihani Katha from a Laghu Katha (short-short story) helped stabilize the genre's identity in a period of

definitional uncertainty, making a concrete scholarly contribution to Maithili creative literary culture through analytical rather than creative means.

The unpublished novel Gahabar Ke Bat par (On the Path to the Sangarama), set against the background of the Buddhist Sangarama (monastery) of ancient Mithila, is described in the special issue as addressing the perennial tensions between religious orthodoxy and social justice, between the authority of institutional religion and the ethical demands of individual conscience. The reviewer Sunil Kumar 'Bhanu' identifies it as a 'unique entity' in Maithili fiction precisely because it uses the historical imagination — always Jha's primary intellectual mode — to illuminate present-day social and ethical problems. The choice of a Buddhist setting is particularly apt: Buddhism, as the intellectual heritage of the region where Navya-Nyaya was also born, provides a natural bridge between Jha's scholarly and literary identities.

## 10. Sociological and Institutional Dimensions

Dr. Kailash Kumar Mishra's essay, 'Mithilak Jivit Manav Dharohar' (Mithila's Living Human Heritage), raises the institutional question most directly: how can Bhavnath Jha's expertise be preserved and transmitted? Mishra suggests that Jha should form a training team (dal) of young researchers, mentoring them systematically rather than working as a solitary soldier (senapati). He raises the question of funding — whether corporate social responsibility funds from Mithila or Bihar industrial enterprises could support this — and suggests that a structured platform for crowd-funding might be viable.

Bhairav Lal Das's essay on Jha's research methodology makes a similar point from a different angle: the next generation of Maithili manuscript scholars needs systematic training, and Jha is uniquely positioned to provide it. The interview itself concludes with Jha's invitation to young researchers to contact him for guidance in the field of palaeography — a generous offer that reflects both his commitment to knowledge transfer and his awareness of his own irreplaceability as a traditional-modern synthesizer.

The institutional location at Mahavir Mandir — a Hindu temple trust that is one of the most financially powerful religious institutions in Bihar — provides Bhavnath Jha with both stability and access to a specific cultural agenda (the promotion of Vaishnava Sanatan culture, the edition of Sanskrit religious texts).

This institutional context shapes his editorial output: the majority of his edited works are Vaishnava or Shaiva Sanskrit texts published by the Mandir's Dharmayan journal. This is not a limitation but a definition: his is a culturally located, institutionally embedded scholarship, and the Navya-Nyaya epistemologist would note that acknowledging this context is part of the intellectual honesty (apta-vacana) that makes his scholarship trustworthy.

## 11. Reception and Significance

The reception of the Videha special issue — as documented in the reader responses published in the first pages of the issue itself — reflects a range of positions that together constitute a rich collective evaluation. Ajit Kumar Jha, writing from Delhi, admits he had never heard of Bhavnath Jha before the issue announcement, and his response — a detailed, engaged reading of every section of the issue — models the kind of intellectual discovery that the special issue was designed to produce. Dr. Kailash Kumar Mishra (Delhi) provides the most authoritative assessment, calling the issue 'extremely important' and noting that it represents genuine scholarly documentation rather than mere institutional flattery.

The Wikipedia article on Mahavir Mandir, Patna, confirms Bhavnath Jha's institutional prominence: he is identified as the current editor of Dharmayan, the temple trust's scholarly journal — a position that places him at the centre of one of Bihar's most significant cultural-religious publishing enterprises. Mahavir Mandir publication pages list Jha as editor or co-editor of numerous Sanskrit texts, confirming the breadth of his published output. The Academia.edu paper on the Buddhacharitam restoration demonstrates his international academic reach, as does his Resource Person role for C-DAC Mysore's Tirhuta font development and the National Translation Mission's Sanskrit web-content translation workshops.

Vijay Deo Jha's English essay — the only English-language contribution in the special issue — explicitly frames Bhavnath Jha for an international readership, situating his work within the global context of Indological scholarship: 'Most importantly, his remarkable works in the field of Indology, historical research, rediscovering and reconstructing the lost and forgotten treasures of knowledge and the knowledge tradition of Mithila won accolades for him.' This international framing is itself a critical act: it claims for Bhavnath Jha's

regional, script-specialized scholarship a place in the global conversation about the preservation and interpretation of South Asian heritage.

## 12. Conclusion

Pandit Bhavnath Jha represents a convergence of forces that is rare in any scholarly tradition: the unbroken inheritance of a specific technical knowledge (traditional palaeography and epigraphy, transmitted through his father and the Mithila pandit lineage); sustained formal education in both traditional Sanskrit and modern humanities disciplines; institutional support without institutional constraint; and a programmatic vision of what needs to be done for Mithila's intellectual heritage that has directed his career with unwavering focus for more than three decades.

The critical frameworks applied in this report — Indian aesthetic theory, Western critical theory, and the Navya-Nyaya epistemology of Mithila's own Gangesa Upadhyaya — converge on a common assessment: Bhavnath Jha's significance is not merely literary but epistemological. His work is fundamentally about what can be known, and how it can be known, about the past from manuscript and epigraphic evidence. In this, he is a direct heir of Gangesa's methodological rigour — the insistence that knowledge-claims be established through multiple pramanas, that presumptive validity is not sufficient, that the extrinsic validation of text-claims through comparison, historical cross-reference, and stylistic analysis is necessary.

The Videha special issue performs an important function by making Jha's work visible to Maithili readers who might otherwise remain unaware of it. But the work of critical appreciation is only beginning. A sustained monograph-length study of his Buddhacharitam restoration, a full philological analysis of his Agastya Samhita edition, a critical edition of Bhrunapanchasika with Sanskrit commentary — these are the scholarly projects that the present report identifies as necessary next steps. Bhavnath Jha has planted seeds; the task of the scholarly community is to cultivate them.

In Gangesa's terms: the pratyaksha evidence (Jha's actual published works) is before us; the anumana (what can be inferred about their significance) is being built; the upamana (how they compare with the best in their fields) is becoming clearer; and the shabda (the reliable testimony of those who have worked with him) is now available in systematic form through the Videha special issue. The

four pramanas converge on a single conclusion: Pandit Bhavnath Jha is one of the most significant scholarly figures in contemporary Maithili cultural life, and the recognition he has received through this special issue is both overdue and insufficient. Much more awaits.

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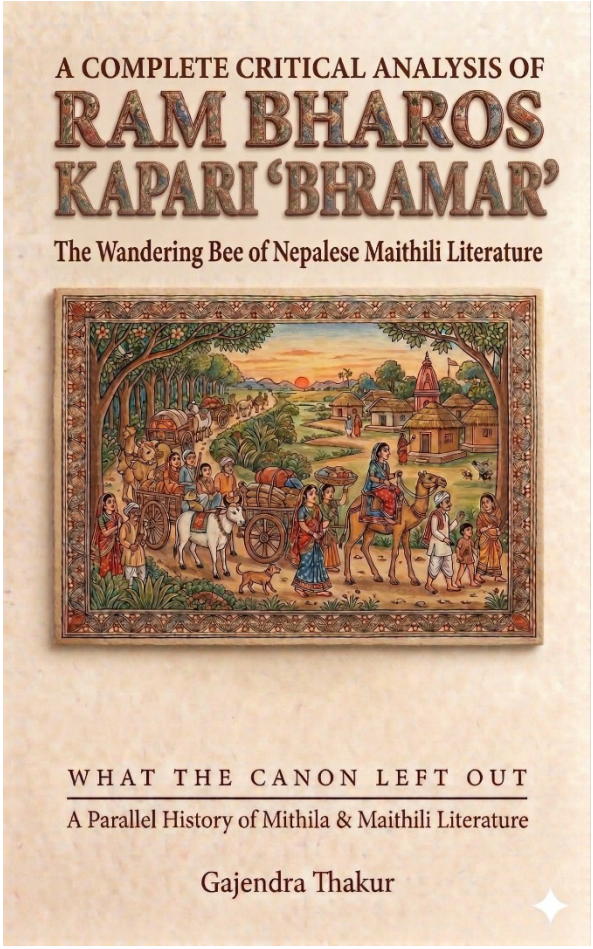


# A COMPLETE CRITICAL ANALYSIS

*of*

# RAM BHAROS

**KAPARI 'BHRAMAR'**

*The Wandering Bee of Nepalese Maithili Literature*

With Application of Indian and Western Literary Theories

*Based on Videha Special Issue 370 (2023) and Published Works*

# PART I: Biographical and Historical Context

## 1.1 Life, Origins, and Formation

Ram Bharos Kapari 'Bhramar' — the pen name 'Bhramar' (the bumblebee) chosen with deliberate poetic intent — was born on 22 Sawan 2008 Vikram Samvat (corresponding to 5 May 1951 CE) in Baichawa village, Dhanusha district, Janakpur zone, in the Madhesh region of southern Nepal. His father, the late Ramgulam Kapari, was a respected community leader and village headman (pradhan panch) who served three consecutive terms — a man of substantial landholding, village influence, and social prestige whom the community addressed as 'Adhikari'. His mother was the late Dukhani Devi. The family was among the most prosperous in the area, a material security that would later free Bhramar from the obligations of salaried employment and allow him to pursue full-time literary work — making him, as he himself noted, 'the only full-time writer in Maithili literature.'

Bhramar's early education began in the village chaatsaar (traditional school) with a teacher named Ganesh Lal Karna, who taught him the alphabet in the earth itself — writing with a finger in soil and on slates, a pedagogic image of earthy rootedness that runs through all his later folk-culture scholarship. After three years at the Belhi Middle School near Baichawa, he moved to Janakpur's Saraswati High School for his SLC (School Leaving Certificate), and then to Ramswayrup Ramsagar Bahumulkhi Campus in Janakpur — an affiliate of Tribhuvan University — for his IA, BA, and finally his MA in Maithili, which he completed in the first batch (first division) when the postgraduate programme was established there through the efforts of Dr. Dhireshwar Jha 'Dhirendra'.

The most decisive formative influence was Dr. Dhireshwar Jha 'Dhirendra', who lived near his home in Janakpur, taught at the campus, and became both a literary mentor and a kind of surrogate intellectual father. Bhramar himself states categorically: 'If Dr. Dhirendra had not been there, I would probably not have become a writer.' It was Dhirendra who redirected his early Hindi-language story draft into Maithili — recognizing the boy's gift and insisting on

the mother tongue as the medium. Bhramar's first published work, a children's story called 'Imaandaar Balak' (The Honest Child), appeared in the prestigious Maithili weekly Mithila Mihir in 1964, when he was just twelve years old. From that moment, he signed all his work with the pen name 'Bhramar.'

Bhramar married Daltiya Devi from Bhagwanpatti village in Dhanusha district during his adolescence — a detail that speaks to the region's social customs of early marriage. They have three sons: Ram Narayan Kapari (editor of the Janakpur Express daily and a political activist), Pradeep Kumar Kapari (employed with Nepal Food Corporation), and Sandeep Kumar Kapari (a computer graphics expert running his own business). Two daughters are also married. His wife's attachment to Janakpur (and resistance to moving to Kathmandu) is actually an autobiographical thread that surfaces in his fiction, most notably in the story collection Anti-Virus.

## 1.2 Professional Career: The Independent Literary Life

Bhramar made a decisive choice: despite completing a Master's degree in Maithili — the qualification that would have made him a university professor — he rejected academic employment. This was not penury but principle. As he explains in his interview with Vijay Kumar Mishra (Videha 370): 'I chose journalism, independent writing, research, and travel. Because I had economic sufficiency, the thought of a job never entered my mind. I am a free spirit and chose to live independently.'

His journalism career began in 2026-27 Vikram Samvat as a representative of the Vaidehee Weekly in Janakpur. After the political changes of 2046 BS (1989 CE), when multiparty democracy was established and private media began to flourish, he became Kantipur Daily's Janakpur correspondent, a position he held for five years. Through his editorial efforts, he produced the Maithili journal Archana from 2030 BS — the first Maithili periodical dedicated purely to literary content in Nepal — which ran continuously for over twelve years (62 issues are documented). He went on to edit Anjuli (monthly, Nepali) and Aanjur (bimonthly, Maithili), and most significantly, founded Gamhar Maithili Weekly in 2039 BS — Nepal's first and still-running Maithili newspaper, now approaching four decades of continuous publication. He also founded Janakpur Express, a Nepali daily, in 2055 BS, whose editorial direction passes to his son Ram Narayan.

His institutional career reached its apex when the Nepali government appointed him as the first Madhesi President of Sajha Prakashan (the state publishing house in Lalitpur) — a historic appointment that broke the existing Nepali-

language hegemony of that institution. Under his brief tenure, he introduced Maithili publications into Sajha's catalogue for the first time. He subsequently served as a member of the Pragya Parishad (Nepal Academy's Council) for four years. He currently serves as Chairperson of the Madhesh Pragya Pratisthan, established by the Madhesh Province government to promote regional languages and cultures.

## 1.3 The Name 'Bhramar' and Its Significance

The pen name 'Bhramar' (the bumblebee) was adopted at the time of his Matric examination, when he attempted to include it on his official form — an attempt that his headmaster rejected with the dismissive comment 'everyone wants to become a poet.' The rejection became the catalyst: Bhramar turned the name into a lifelong commitment, a declarative identity. The bee is a creature that wanders (bhramar = wanderer, also = bumblebee), pollinates, and produces honey. It is also associated in Sanskrit aesthetics with the bee that hovers around a lotus — a classical image of the devotee/lover in search of beauty and nectar. This double resonance — the wandering explorer of diverse literary fields who also produces the 'honey' of art — is entirely apt for a writer who has worked across every conceivable genre for six decades.

## 1.4 Bhramar in the Context of Nepalese Maithili Literature

Maithili literature in Nepal has existed in a doubly marginalised position: excluded from the mainstream of Indian Maithili literature (which is institutionally centred in Bihar) and simultaneously under-recognised within Nepal, where Nepali language has historically dominated cultural institutions. Bhramar has been the most prominent voice advocating for the recognition of Nepalese Maithili writers by India's Sahitya Akademi — a structural inequity where Nepal's Maithili authors are systematically excluded from the national literary awards and anthologies that their Indian counterparts receive. As he stated to the Himalayan Times, Madhesh Province 'allocates Rs. 250-300 million for road projects, but has not even allocated Rs. 40 million for the protection and promotion of languages.' His five decades of work represent the most sustained single-person effort to build the infrastructure of Maithili literary and cultural life on the Nepali side of the border.

# PART II: Works — A Comprehensive Survey

## 2.1 Poetry

***Bann Kothari Aunait Dhuaan (Smouldering Smoke in a Closed Room, 2029 BS / 1972 CE)***

Bhramar's debut poetry collection takes its title from an image of oppression and suppressed anger: smoke that cannot escape a sealed room, burning the very person it was meant to warm. This is the foundational metaphor of his early poetics — the trapped human condition under social exploitation. Critic Ashwini Kumar Alok reads this collection as saying: 'People understand that those responsible for their exploitation and oppression will be brought down on the day that the torch of resistance and revolution is lit. But this cannot happen easily. The fire in a person smoulders inside them, burns them, and their body stands helpless like a sealed room, their smoke tormenting them.' This is the vocabulary of a social-realist poetry that blames systemic oppression for the individual's inward burning.

***Nahi, Ab Nahi (No More, No More) — Long Poem, 2036 BS / 1979 CE),***

This long poem (deergh kavita) is possibly Bhramar's most widely known individual work. It was translated into Nepali as 'Bhayo Ab Bhayo' by the distinguished Nepali poet Manu Bajracharya, and into Hindi as 'Bas Ab Nahin' — multiple translations testifying to its cultural reach. The poem is a sustained expression of accumulated human fatigue and rebellion: the repeated refrain of 'no more' captures the moment at which the tolerated becomes intolerable, when suffering crosses its threshold and demands transformation. It was published in the Nepal Academy's journal Pragya and in Archana, Bhramar's own journal. Chanresh's essay in Videha 370 characterises this as emblematic of Bhramar's poetics — 'the honest courage to put one's viewpoint clearly' — a poetry that is simultaneously personal lament and collective call.

***Momak Pahlait Adhar (Lips Melting Like Wax, 2047 BS / 1990 CE) — Geet-Ghazal Collection***

This collection of songs and ghazals demonstrates Bhramar's lyrical range: the erotic and the romantic — the lips melting with desire — in contrast to the political anger of his earlier poetry. From his student days, Bhramar compiled a songbook called 'Jawaaniik Din' (Days of Youth) at age fourteen, and several of his songs became widely popular: notably a holi song for the Nepali film 'Sita',

and 'Sakhi He Saawan ke Bunn Jhisi' from the Maithili telefilm 'Ekta Aor Basant', which became a significant hit. His music video album 'Arripen' (Nine Songs) was also produced.

***Apan Anachinhaar (My Unknown One, 2047 BS / 1990 CE) and Yudhbhoomik Esgar Yoddha (Lone Warrior on the Battlefield of Life, 2075 BS / 2017 CE)***

These two collections bracket the arc of his poetic career. Apan Anachinhaar belongs to his mature mid-career — the search for the beloved/self through the category of the unknown, the unrecognised. Yudhbhoomik Esgar Yoddha is his most recent major poetry collection, published in 2017, marking six decades of literary output. The title is a self-portrait: the lone fighter on life's battlefield.

***Anhariyak Chaan (Moon in Darkness, 2070 BS / 2013 CE) — Ghazal Collection***

The ghazal, a form of Arabic-Persian origin adopted widely into Urdu, Hindi, and through Bhramar's work into Maithili, operates through the strict formal requirements of the radif (refrain), qafia (rhyme), and the beloved/divine addressee. Bhramar's Maithili ghazals represent a significant formal experiment — bringing the ghazal's traditional themes of love, wine, and mystical longing into a Maithili linguistic and cultural idiom. Critic Vinay Bhushan (Videha 370) specifically analyses these ghazals as 'lighting the lamp of hope' — ghazals that carry simultaneously personal affect and social aspiration. One representative ghazal from the Nepal Academy's journal Kavita reads: 'Gazal gayiki ho tarang zindagiko / Bhav hanita ho tarang zindagiko' (Ghazal singing is the wave of life / Feeling and yearning is the wave of life). The ghazal here is reframed not as personal romantic complaint but as the surge of life itself.

## 2.2 Fiction

***Tora Sange Jaibau Re Kujba (I Will Go with You, Dear Cuckoo, 1987 CE)***

Bhramar's first story collection was published — significantly — by the Maithili Academy of Bihar, India (not a Nepali institution), a milestone he claims makes it 'the first modern Maithili story collection from Nepal published by a Bihar government institution.' The title evokes the kujba (the cuckoo), a bird associated in Maithili folk culture with the arrival of spring and the yearning of love. The stories deal with the social realities of the Mithila region: village life, interpersonal relationships, the tensions of modernity.

### *Hoogli Upar Bahait Ganga (The Ganga Flowing Above the Hooghly, 2065 BS / 2008 CE)*

The paradoxical image of the Ganga 'flowing above' the Hooghly is a geographical and poetic impossibility used metaphorically — the sacred above the secular, the ideal above the actual. Critics describe this collection as showing Bhramar's characteristic sensitivity (gharniya samvedana) and the changing face of the village (badlait gamak swarup). The stories are set in the Mithila countryside — its social structures, its negotiations with urbanisation and modernisation.

### *Anti-Virus (2076 BS / 2019 CE)*

Bhramar's third story collection bears a deliberately contemporary title: the antivirus program that detects and eliminates digital viruses becomes a metaphor for literature's function in detecting and neutralising social pathologies. Dr. Ramdayal Rakesh's detailed critical reading (Videha 370) examines the collection story by story:

The title story 'Anti-Virus' is semi-autobiographical: a couple in Kathmandu, where the writer has come for institutional work, navigates the city together. The wife refuses to go to Kathmandu at all — 'not even a cup of tea could she find joy there' — while he worries about the 'virus' that threatens domestic life: another woman cooking in his kitchen. The virus of marital jealousy is presented with wry humour.

'ICU' draws on the experience of a seriously ill brother in a Darbhanga hospital — the agony of watching a loved one between life and death. 'Amrit Paan' (Drinking Nectar) dramatises the social-cultural dimension of the Madhesh Movement: the inability to send festival messages home, the sweetness of tilwa and chivda in contrast to the bitterness of political disruption. 'Parivatan' (Change) depicts marital conflict with an acute study of divergent cultural expectations between rural and urban. 'Muniya Tea Stall' is a folk-realistic story of a beautiful tea stall owner whose customers come as much for her as for the tea, until she runs off with a young man — 'the most talked-about event in the village.' Its resolution through folk comedy is deft.

The collection's masterpiece (master-piece) is identified by Rakesh as 'Annadhan Lakshmi' — a story of a rural woman made pregnant through deception, abandoned, and then victimised again. The story's power lies in its portrayal of feminine suffering and social double-standards without sentimentalising: the woman is simultaneously betrayed by a man and victimised by another woman's jealousy. Yet the story ends hopefully — a

deliberate sukhant (happy ending) that Rakesh identifies as a feature of Bhramar's story-telling philosophy: the light at the end of the tunnel. 'Sona' depicts the India-Nepal border as a zone of shared family pain: 'a white pillar that stares at them like a ghost.'

## 2.3 Novel: Gharmuha (The One Who Yearns for Home, 2069 BS / 2012 CE)

Bhramar's only novel to date is his most politically significant work. Published in 2012 — the same year as six other major Maithili novels — Gharmuha is the first Nepalese Maithili novel set against a contemporary political event: the Madhesh Movement of 2006-07. As the acclaimed writer and critic Rajendra Vimal writes in his preface: 'Narrative writer Bhramar, eager to tell his generation's authentic story to future generations, has turned this novel into the vocal sibling of mute history. On the ground of political events, using imagination like clay, mortar, sand, and stone, he has created a living portrait of contemporary Madhesh society whose raga of social relationship-bonds has been poured in — and it is heart-touching.'

The novel's title Gharmuha is a Maithili word meaning 'one who faces toward home' — someone in exile who is always mentally oriented toward return. The novelist himself explains: 'The central character's mental state, his attachment and love for his birthplace, and despite displacement, his extraordinary enthusiasm and vitality to return home whenever the opportunity arises — this gives saaarthakta (meaningfulness) to the word Gharmuha.' The novel is dedicated, through its emotional architecture, to the proposition that home (ghar) is defined not by ethnicity or caste but by human affection, relationships, and love.

The plot unfolds during the Madhesh agitation: Ramesh Upadhyay, a schoolteacher of Pahadi (hill-origin) identity living in the Madhesh for decades, finds himself trapped between his genuine support for the movement's goals and the violence of criminal elements who have infiltrated it under its cover. His daughter Kiran, who is in love with Rajiv — the son of Kameshwar Singh, a locally respected man who is secretly the criminal mastermind behind kidnapping and extortion — is abducted. The ransom demand of ten lakhs forces the teacher to sell his home. Rajiv, discovering his father's crimes, works through his mother to pressure Kameshwar into releasing Kiran. Eventually, through the mediation of Jagmohan — Ramesh's Madhesi friend — the teacher is brought home, the kidnapping resolved, and the two young lovers given the blessing of both families.

Rajendra Vimal's critical reading emphasises the novel's political documentary value: it records the specific dates of failed negotiations (1 June 2007, 25 July, 28 July, 5 August 2007, and the 30 August agreement on 26 points) with a journalist's precision — making it 'an historical document' as much as a novel. The language is described as deploying Madhesh-Mithila folk vocabulary ('lallhka', 'labhka', 'badhka', 'khusingh') that gives the narrative 'natural, authentic, and innovative' quality. The narrative pace is cinematic — 'not the difficult mountain path, but the straight smooth plain road that reaches its destination flowing easily.'

The novel has been translated into Hindi (by Dr. Prfull Kumar Singh 'Maun'), Bhojpuri (by Uma Shankar Dwivedi), and is understood to exist in Nepali translation as well. The Ganki Dhuswaan Basundhara Prize of Rs. 50,000 was awarded specifically for this novel.

## 2.4 Drama

Bhramar's theatre is among his most celebrated contributions. He has written over a dozen plays — short and long, historical and contemporary, experimental and folk-derived — and his drama represents a sustained attempt to establish a viable Maithili theatrical tradition in Nepal.

Rani Chandravati (2045 BS / 1988 CE) is a historical drama. The title character is a historical Maithil queen. Ekta Aor Vasant (One More Spring, 2052 BS / 1995 CE) became Bhramar's most widely performed play — it was staged at Nepal Rajkiya Pragya Pratisthan (Nepal Academy) and has gone through three editions. A telefilm based on it was broadcast on Nepal Television. Mahishasur Murdabad (Death to Mahishasura, 2054 BS / 1997 CE) is a political play whose title invokes the demon from Hindu mythology as a metaphor for contemporary oppressive power. Bhaiya Aelai Apan Soraj (Brother Has Come for His Own Dawn, 2067 BS / 2010 CE) is a play about political rights and liberation. Suli Par Ijot (Light on the Gallows, 2072 BS / 2015 CE) — a profound and evocative title suggesting martyrdom and illumination simultaneously — has been described as worthy of international recognition.

Bhramar also writes monodramas (one-character plays) — including one on 'Muniya Tea Stall Wali', a character drawn from his fiction. His collected plays were translated into Nepali by Dharmendra Jha 'Vivhal' as 'Bhramaraka Sarvashreshtha Natakaharu' (Bhramar's Best Plays, 2064 BS / 2007 CE). A significant anthology of Maithili plays, Maithili Natak Sangra (2067 BS), was also published under his editorship.

## 2.5 Folk Culture Scholarship and Research

Bhramar's most distinctive contribution to Maithili literature may be his deep scholarly engagement with folk culture, folk art, and folk mythology — an engagement that spans decades of fieldwork and over a dozen research publications.

His research monographs include: Janakpurdham Ra Nyaas Kshetraka Sanskritic Sampada (Cultural Heritage of Janakpur and Its Environs, 2056 BS), Cultural Heritage of Janakpur (English, 2062 BS), Lok Naatya: Jat-Jatin (Folk Drama: Jat-Jatin, 2064 BS) — a study of the classic Maithili folk performance tradition, Maithili Lok Sanskriti Alekh Sangra (Maithili Folk Culture Essay Collection, 2066 BS), Mithilak Saput: Raja Salhesh (Hero of Mithila: King Salhesh, 2075 BS), Maithil Lok Sanskriti: Vividh Aayam (Maithil Folk Culture: Various Dimensions, 2075 BS) — a Nepal Academy publication.

His most recent major work, Mithilak Lokjeevan: Lok Sandarbha (Mithila's Folk Life: Folk Reference), launched in Janakpur with distinguished guests from Patna, Kolkata, Darbhanga, and Kathmandu, represents the culmination of four decades of fieldwork and research. Bhimnath Jha's essay in Videha 370 describes this work as 'encyclopaedic' — a work that Maithili expatriates around the world can use as 'a Mithila directory,' covering literature, culture, history, politics, natural heritage, and the lives of folk deities (Salhesh, Dinabhari, Raja Bharthari) within one unified cultural cartography.

## 2.6 Travelogues, Diaries, and Miscellany

Bhramar's travelogue Cheen Je Ham Dekhal (China As I Saw It, 2070 BS / 2013 CE) documents his visit to China — a rare example of Maithili travel writing about East Asia. Seemaa Mein Aar-Paar (Across the Border, 2073 BS / 2016 CE) explores the Nepal-India borderland and its human geography. Koronaak Sanwaas Mein Ojhrayal Jindagi (Life Tangled in the Breath of Corona, 2020 CE) is a lockdown diary — a literary response to the COVID-19 pandemic that joins a growing global archive of pandemic writing. Ahaan Je Kahluhun (Whatever You Said, 2071 BS) is an interview collection.

# PART III: Critical Appreciation through Literary Theories

## 3.1 Social Realism and Progressive Literature

Bhramar belongs firmly to the tradition of progressive (pragativaadi) literature — the movement associated in Hindi and Maithili with the influence of the Progressive Writers' Association (1936), Marxist politics, and the commitment to depicting the lives of the oppressed and the exploited. Chanresh's essay in Videha 370 describes his vision as consistently directed toward 'the exploited and oppressed society — the truth of their experience — awakening human sensitivity to moral values.'

In his poetry collection Bann Kothari Aunait Dhuaan, the imprisoned smoke is the consciousness of the exploited class: it knows its oppressors but cannot act. In 'Nahi, Ab Nahi', the accumulated negation is the historical moment of revolutionary refusal — the poem of the subaltern who says 'enough.' This situates Bhramar squarely within what Georg Lukács called 'critical realism' — a literature that maps social reality with sufficient fidelity to reveal the structural conditions of oppression, rather than merely depicting surface events. Unlike 'naturalism' (which Lukács critiques as recording detail without interpretation), Bhramar's realism carries interpretation within its imagery: the sealed room, the moon in darkness, the gallows with its light.

His story collection Anti-Virus extends this realism into the contemporary moment: the corruption of political movements by criminal opportunism ('Sona', 'Amrit Paan'), the economic pressures on remittance families ('Udaan', 'Dahej'), the commodification of gender ('Muniya Tea Stall', 'Annadhan Lakshmi'). The antivirus metaphor itself is a contribution to progressive aesthetic vocabulary: literature as the program that identifies and purges social pathology.

## 3.2 Postcolonial Theory: Language Rights, Linguistic Marginalisation, and the Madhesh

Perhaps the most productive theoretical lens for Bhramar's work is postcolonial theory — specifically, the theory of linguistic colonialism and the politics of cultural survival for minority language communities. Maithili in Nepal occupies a doubly subaltern position: marginalised both by the Nepali-language national culture and by the India-centric Maithili literary establishment that largely ignores Nepalese Maithili writers.

Bhramar's entire literary project can be read as an act of cultural decolonisation — the systematic construction of an infrastructure for Maithili literary life in Nepal. His founding of Archana, Gamhar, and Aanjur; his editions of poetry anthologies and folk culture collections; his presidency of Sajha Prakashan where he introduced Maithili publications; his advocacy for Maithili recognition as a provincial official language — all constitute what Ngugi wa Thiong'o called the 'decolonisation of the mind,' the reclamation of a suppressed cultural identity through the medium of the suppressed language.

His complaint to the Himalayan Times about Madhesh Province's Rs. 40 million allocation for language promotion versus Rs. 250-300 million for roads is a precise formulation of what Frantz Fanon identified as the characteristic investment pattern of postcolonial states: infrastructure over culture, roads over tongues. Bhramar's political activism around Maithili recognition translates directly into his literary theory: a language without institutional support cannot sustain a literary culture. Homi Bhabha's concept of the 'Third Space' — the location of cultural negotiation between dominant and subordinate — is visible in Bhramar's practice: he works simultaneously in Maithili (India and Nepal), Nepali, and Hindi, navigating between national literary systems while asserting Maithili identity within all of them.

The novel Gharmuha is the most direct literary engagement with this postcolonial condition. The Madhesh Movement — a movement for the recognition of Madhesi (Terai) identity, language, and rights within Nepal's federal structure — is the novel's political substrate. The hill-origin teacher Ramesh Upadhyay, though himself an ethnic outsider, has been absorbed into the Madhesh's social fabric: the movement's violence threatens this earned belonging. The novel's resolution — the two families uniting across the Pahadi-Madhesi divide — is an act of utopian postcolonial imagining: the possibility of a multicultural belonging not based on ethnic purity.

## 3.3 Subaltern Studies and the Politics of Representation

Bhramar has explicitly identified himself as a representative of the non-Brahmin (Brahmannetar) community within Maithili literature — a literary culture whose canonical voices have historically been Brahmin-caste. As Dinesh Yadav's essay (Videha 370) notes with admiration: 'The way in which someone from a Brahmannetar community has asserted presence in Maithili literature, which has been historically dominated by Brahminism, is not only unequalled but matchless.' This is a Dalit/OBC politics of representation that

does not require Bhramar to be anti-Brahmin but simply demands the recognition of non-Brahmin voices and subjects within the literary mainstream.

The Subaltern Studies framework of Ranajit Guha and Gayatri Spivak is relevant here. Spivak's question 'Can the subaltern speak?' finds a partial but important answer in Bhramar's work: yes, but only through sustained institutional labour — founding journals, establishing publishing infrastructure, building cultural institutions. The subaltern can speak, but requires platforms that are not controlled by the hegemonic group. Bhramar spent five decades building those platforms.

His folk culture scholarship is itself an exercise in recovering subaltern knowledge: the oral traditions of Salhesh (a folk deity worshipped primarily by Musahar and other lower-caste communities), Dinabhari (another folk epic), and Jat-Jatin (a folk performance tradition) are all cultural expressions that exist outside the Brahmin-Sanskritic literary canon that has historically defined 'Maithili culture.' By documenting, analysing, and publishing these traditions, Bhramar performs what Michel Foucault called 'counter-memory' — the recovery of suppressed historical experience against the dominant archive.

## 3.4 Feminist Theory: Women, Agency, and Voice

Bhramar's engagement with women's experience is significant across genres. His research monograph 'Rajkamal ki Katha Sahitya Mein Naari' (Women in Rajkamal Chaudhary's Fiction, 2064 BS) positions him as a critical reader of feminist themes in Maithili's most rebellious modern writer. Chanresh notes of his early fiction: 'in his previous compositions, he can be called an expert on female psychology (naari manobhaav).' The erotic directness of Momak Pahlait Adhar speaks to a non-prudish literary sexuality — the body as site of beauty and longing, not shame.

In the Anti-Virus collection, 'Annadhan Lakshmi' is the central feminist text: a woman abandoned after being made pregnant, betrayed by a man at work, and then victimised by another woman's jealousy at a deeper level. The story's moral universe is unsparing about patriarchal complicity — both male and female — in women's subordination. Yet its 'sukhant' (happy ending) represents a refusal of the feminist tragedy narrative: these women survive, and some emerge with agency.

'Parivatan' (Change) in the same collection depicts marital conflict through two voices — a wife who has fully assimilated the expectations of a 'modern' marriage, and a husband who is simultaneously modern in aspiration and

traditional in execution. The domestic is political, in the classic feminist formulation. The 'virus' of 'Anti-Virus' title story — the wife's anxiety about another woman in their domestic space — is rendered with psychological acuity rather than moralising.

## 3.5 Rasa Theory and Indian Aesthetic (Bharata's Natyashastra)

Bhramar's drama — perhaps his most formally conscious literary practice — is most productively read through the Indian aesthetic tradition of Rasa theory. The eight rasas of Bharata's Natyashastra — shringara (love/beauty), hasya (humour), karuna (compassion/sorrow), raudra (fury), veer (heroism), bhayanaka (fear), bibhatsa (disgust), and adbhuta (wonder) — all find expression across his dramatic works.

Ekta Aor Vasant (One More Spring) is primarily a play of shringara and karuna: the spring that returns despite oppression, the love that persists through difficulty. The title's double meaning — spring as season, spring as political renewal — operates through the Sanskrit aesthetic principle of 'dhvani' (resonance, suggestion), where multiple meanings are generated from a single image. Suli Par Ijot (Light on the Gallows) works through the Veer (heroic) and Adbhuta (wondrous) rasas: the gallows become a symbol of sacrificial heroism, and the light upon them — rather than darkness — generates aesthetic wonder. Mahishasur Murdabad deploys Raudra (fury) against the demonic social order.

His ghazals, particularly in Anhariyak Chaan, operate through the classical Shringara rasa — but inflected with Karuna: the moon in darkness is both erotic image (the beloved's face) and social image (hope in adversity). The aesthetic pleasure of the ghazal form — its strict formal requirements, its makhta (signature verse), its traditional topoi — is harnessed to social content, creating what the Sanskrit tradition calls 'lokottara' (transcendent) aesthetic experience: that which goes beyond the ordinary.

## 3.6 Narratological Analysis: Journalism and Fiction

A significant structural feature of Bhramar's fiction — particularly Gharmuha — is the interpenetration of journalistic documentary technique and novelistic narrative. Rajendra Vimal identifies this as both a strength and a distinctive character: the novel records specific dates of political negotiations, names actual protest leaders (Upendra Yadav), and deploys the factual precision of the reporter within the emotional latitude of the novelist.

In narratological terms (drawing on Gérard Genette and Seymour Chatman), Bhramar works with a cinematic narrative mode — rapid scene-changes, dramatic dialogue, physical action that carries ideological weight. Vimal's cinematic metaphor — 'like a reel unrolling from beginning to end' — captures the narrative's external orientation: Bhramar is not an interior monologue novelist but a storyteller who relies on action, dialogue, and social event. This is consistent with his journalistic training and his theatre background: both arts that privilege the external, the visible, the spoken.

Chanresh's essay identifies a hierarchy within Bhramar's multi-genre identity: 'I know him as fundamentally a poet and then a story-writer.' This suggests that the internal architecture of his fiction — its imagery, its rhythmic prose, its symbolic titles — is essentially poetic, even when the surface is realistic and journalistic. Henry David Thoreau's aphorism, quoted by Chanresh in the context of Bhramar — 'The greatest artist is one who makes their life the subject of art' — points toward the autobiographical dimension: Bhramar's travels, his institutional battles, his cultural advocacy all become material for his writing.

## 3.7 Oral Tradition, Folk Literature, and the Bhakti Connection

Bhramar's deep engagement with folk culture — Salhesh, Dinabhari, Jat-Jatin — places him in a tradition of Maithili writers who have insisted on the primacy of the oral and the popular over the written and the elite. This connects him to the Bhakti movement's democratic aesthetics: just as Kabir, Vidyapati, and the sants sang in the vernacular to make the divine accessible to all, Bhramar documents and celebrates the divine of the Madhesh poor — the folk deities who protect the lowest castes, the performance traditions that give them voice.

Bhimnath Jha's essay (Videha 370) places Bhramar's Mithilak Lokjeevan in this tradition: 'The scholar discusses medieval song traditions with concern while also swaying to the rhythm of Tirhutiya songs. On one side he searches for traditional kirtan traditions in Mithila, while on the other he shows various forms of children's songs (shishu-geet). He shares the joy of seasonal songs — rain, holi, and spring — then introduces us to the cultural importance of the Ganga and Kamala rivers.' This is the methodology of the folk scholar as cultural activist: documentation in service of preservation and revitalization.

The folk deity Salhesh is particularly significant. Worshipped primarily by Musahar (a Scheduled Caste community considered among the most marginalised in both India and Nepal), Salhesh represents a counter-canonical religious tradition — a divine figure who belongs not to the Sanskrit-Puranic

mainstream but to the oppressed. By publishing two volumes of research on Salhesh (Mithilak Saput: Raja Salhesh and Loknayak Salhesh, two volumes), Bhramar performs an act of cultural decolonisation: he inserts the religious imagination of the Dalit-Madhesi into the archive of 'Maithili culture.'

### 3.8 Reader-Response Theory: The Literary Community

Bhramar's most sustained institutional contribution — the founding and maintenance of journals — can be analysed through a reader-response framework. Wolfgang Iser and Stanley Fish both emphasise that texts are completed through their readers; but Bhramar understands that before a text can be completed, the reader must exist and be given the infrastructure to engage. His journals — Archana, Gamhar, Aanjur, Janakpur Express — are not merely distribution channels but community-building mechanisms. They create readers, not just reach them.

This is what distinguishes Bhramar's role from that of a mere author: he is, in Raymond Williams's terms, a 'cultural worker' who understands that literature is not a private transaction between author and reader but a social practice embedded in institutions. His comment that 'there is no reading culture here' — pointing to the gap between Maithili's large speaker population and its small reading community — is both a diagnosis and a call to action that has structured his entire career.

The interview form, which appears prominently in Videha 370 (interviews with Vijay Kumar Mishra and Dinesh Chandra Gopal), is itself a reader-response instrument: it positions the author as a speaking, responsive, historically situated person rather than an abstracted authorial 'voice.' Bhramar's willingness to be extensively interviewed, to explain his choices, to respond to critics — this openness is itself a democratic gesture consistent with his progressive literary politics.

## PART IV: Bhramar's Place in Maithili and Nepalese Literature

### 4.1 The Cultural Bridge: India and Nepal

Ashwini Kumar Alok's essay in Videha 370 explicitly describes Bhramar as 'the cultural bridge between India and Nepal.' This is not a casual metaphor but a precise description of his institutional role: he has organised three major

International Maithili Conferences in Kathmandu and Janakpur; he is a regular presence at major Maithili events in Darbhanga, Patna, and Kolkata; he has advocated for cross-border literary recognition at the institutional level.

The geographic and cultural reality of Mithila — a region that the Nepal-India border cuts through the middle, separating families, folk traditions, and literary communities that share a common language and heritage — makes Bhramar's bridge-building both necessary and meaningful. His travelogue Seemaa Mein Aar-Paar (Across the Border) is the literary expression of this identity: the border as both a physical reality and a cultural wound that literature can, if not heal, at least refuse to honour.

## 4.2 First Among Firsts: Historical Significance

Chanresh's essay enumerates Bhramar's 'firsts' with the precision of a cultural historian: first recipient of the Mayadevi Pragya Puraskar (2052 BS, Rs. 50,000); first Nepal-published Maithili story collection recognised by Bihar's Maithili Academy ('Tora Sange Jaibau Re Kujba'); author of the first Nepalese Maithili novel set on contemporary political events (Gharmuha); first Madhesi President of Sajha Prakashan; first Maithili writer to become a member of Nepal Pragya Pratisthan's Praagya Parishad; co-founder of Gamhar — Nepal's first and continuously published Maithili newspaper.

These 'firsts' are not vanity: they constitute the material record of a culture's struggle for institutional recognition. Each 'first' is a breach in a wall — the wall of Nepali-language hegemony, or Brahmin-caste cultural gatekeeping, or the India-centric definition of 'Maithili literature.' Bhramar's career is a sustained act of wall-breaching, performed through cultural production and institutional persistence across six decades.

## 4.3 Awards and Recognition

Bhramar has received over a dozen significant awards: Nepal Rajkiya Pragya Pratisthan's first Mayadevi Pragya Puraskar (Rs. 50,000); Mithila Vibhuti Samman from the Vidyapati Seva Sansthan, Darbhanga; Shekhar Samman from Shekhar Prakashan, Patna; Vaidehi Pratibha Puraskar from Maithili Sahitya Parishad, Janakpur; Mithilaratna Samman from the International Maithili Conference, Mumbai; Madhurima Samman; Yatri Chetna Puraskar from Chetna Samiti, Patna; Sajha Lok Sanskriti Puraskar 2068 BS; Nepal Vidyapati Bhasha Sahitya Puraskar 2069 BS (Rs. 2 lakhs — the largest Maithili literary prize); Mithila Vibhuti Samman from Raipur, Chhattisgarh; Keshav Lal Dhakhwa Sirpa Katha Puraskar 2070 BS; Ganki Dhuswaan Basundhara

Puraskar (Rs. 50,000) for Gharmuha; Parvati Samman from Sisodia Salaahi; and others.

# PART V: Final Critical Assessment

## 5.1 Strengths

Bhramar's primary literary strength is his extraordinary range — across every conceivable genre — combined with a consistent political and ethical orientation toward the marginalised. From the compressed political lyricism of his early poetry to the folk-realistic stories of Anti-Virus, from the historical documentary novel Gharmuha to the encyclopaedic scholarship of Mithilak Lokjeevan, he maintains a coherent vision: literature as cultural survival, as social protest, and as the documentation of lives that would otherwise disappear unrecorded.

His contribution to Maithili institutional culture — journals, publishers, newspapers, cultural organisations — is arguably more significant than any single literary work. He is a cultural ecosystem builder, not merely a writer. In a minority-language literary community with weak institutional infrastructure, this is the most important contribution possible. As Bhimnath Jha notes: 'His literary field is abundant. Like a field that yields crops in every season... the fields of those we call 'Sone ki Tukdi' (golden pieces) — all aspects are resplendent in his field.'

His folk culture scholarship fills a genuine lacuna: the documentation of Nepalese Mithila's oral traditions, folk deities, and performance cultures was largely unaddressed before his sustained fieldwork. This scholarly contribution will outlast critical fashions.

## 5.2 Limitations and Critical Reservations

The same critics who celebrate Bhramar's range also note that prolific output across fifty genres can dilute individual works. Chanresh observes that 'writing a large number of books in any genre is not a special quality in itself.' Some works, Rakesh suggests, are 'commissioned' (farmaishi) — written under external pressure — and show it in their flatness. The Anti-Virus collection's weaker stories lack the social precision of the best work; the 'Ijoriya Raatuk Sapna' story is noted as having appeared in so many collections that its inclusion in a new volume is questionable.

The novel Gharmuha, while politically significant, is described by critics as narratively 'linear' — the 'straight, smooth plain road' metaphor is both a compliment (accessible, fluent) and a mild critique (uncomplicated, without the mountainous difficulty of the greatest novels). The political documentary drive sometimes overwhelms the novelistic character development: the dates and negotiations are historically precise, but the inner lives of characters can feel schematic.

The absence of a sustained engagement with Bhramar's work by major critical institutions — Sahitya Akademi India, for instance — is both an injustice (that he himself has protested) and a gap in the critical record. Most critical writing on his work comes from within the Maithili community (Videha, the journals he has himself edited) rather than from outside. A truly external critical perspective on his work remains to be developed.

## 5.3 The 'Bhramar' as Literary Figure

There is a productive irony in the pen name Bhramar. The bumblebee wanders (bhraman) and pollinates — it is the agent of cross-fertilisation between different plants, different literary traditions, different languages. Bhramar has crossed between Maithili and Nepali, between folk and modern, between journalism and fiction, between India and Nepal, between the literary canon and the oral subaltern. This cross-fertilising function — the bee that carries pollen from one cultural tradition to another — may be his most distinctive contribution.

In traditional Indian poetics, the bhramar was also the devotee figure: the bee that seeks the lotus of the divine, hovering and murmuring (bhramar-geet). Bhramar's own ghazal collection Anhariyak Chaan (Moon in Darkness) positions him in this tradition: seeking light in darkness, finding beauty in the most difficult conditions. The moon in the darkness is both the beloved's face and the hope of the oppressed — the persistence of cultural beauty against political adversity.

## 5.4 Historical Legacy

Dinesh Yadav's hyperbolic but revealing epithet — 'the Shakespeare of Maithili' — signals the scale of Bhramar's ambition and recognition within his community. Whether this comparison holds analytically is secondary to what it tells us: within the Nepalese Maithili literary world, Bhramar is the central, defining figure of the modern era. His career spans from 1964 (first published

work) to 2023 and beyond — sixty years of uninterrupted literary production in the most challenging institutional conditions possible for a minority language.

What is certain is that the history of Maithili literature in Nepal cannot be told without Ram Bharos Kapari 'Bhramar.' He is simultaneously its most productive author, its most important institution-builder, its most consistent cultural advocate, and — through his folk-culture scholarship — its most dedicated archivist. These four functions together constitute a literary career of extraordinary historical significance, regardless of the final aesthetic judgment on any individual work.

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Scribd Archive: Multiple Bhramar texts available including 'Gharmuha' (Upanyas), 'Ab Bas Nahin' (Hindi Anuwad), 'Anhariyak Chaan' (Gajal Sangrah).

## Theoretical Frameworks Referenced

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Wolfgang Iser: The Act of Reading (1978) — Reader-response analysis of Bhramar's journals.

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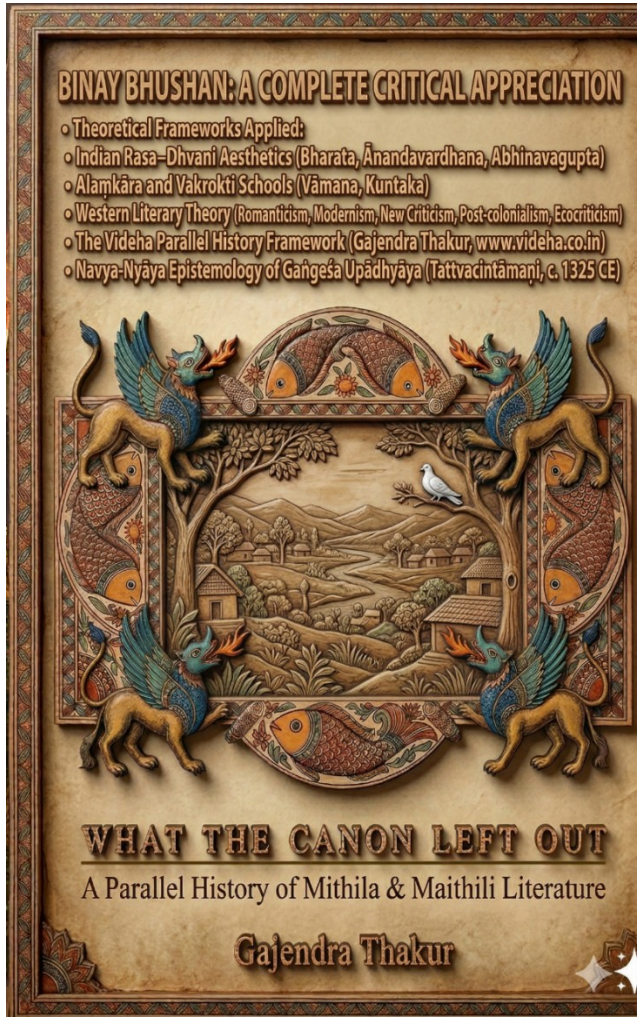
**LESSON 020 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**



# BINAY BHUSHAN: A COMPLETE CRITICAL APPRECIATION

## A Comprehensive Research Report Integrating Indian and Western Literary Theory, the Videha Parallel History Framework, and Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya

**Theoretical Frameworks Applied:** - Indian Rasa–Dhvani Aesthetics (Bharata, Ānandavardhana, Abhinavagupta) - Alaṃkāra and Vakrokti Schools (Vāmana, Kuntaka) - Western Literary Theory (Romanticism, Modernism, New Criticism, Post-colonialism, Ecocriticism) - The Videha Parallel History Framework (Gajendra Thakur, www.videha.co.in) - Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (*Tattvacintāmaṇi*, c. 1325 CE)

## PART I: BIOGRAPHICAL AND CONTEXTUAL OVERVIEW

### *1.1 Life and Identity*

Binay Bhushan (बिनय भूषण) is a contemporary Maithili poet born on **6 November 1968** in the Madhepura district of Bihar. His address is given as Madhepura, Pin 852124 — situating him firmly in the Koshi-anchal (Koshi basin region) of north Bihar, a flood-plain geography historically associated with agrarian hardship, cultural resilience, and the eastern margins of the Maithili-speaking world. His educational background includes a B.A. in History and an M.A., which provide the intellectual substrate visible in his poetry's engagement with time, memory, and civilizational continuity.

His professional life encompasses government service (*sarkārī naukri*), journalism (*patrakāritā*), and writing (*lekhana*) — a triple vocation that connects him to a broad tradition of Maithili writers who have balanced creative work with public life. His declared areas of intellectual interest include spiritualism (*ādhyātmikatā*), comparative religion (*taulanātmaka dharma*), and environmentalism (*paryāvaraṇa*) — a triangulation that defines the deep thematic architecture of *Ujāra Parbak Khoj*.

His contact is listed at 9874274019 and his publisher Bhorukawa Publication (Email: bhorukaba@yahoo.com), located at 20, Baktiar Shah Road,

Kolkata-700007, is a Kolkata-based Maithili publishing house that has published several works in the Videha-adjacent parallel tradition. The distributor Aadhutta Aart, 69, Ashapathi Lane, Kolkata-700007 (tel: 09748120990, 09883072050) rounds out the network of the Kolkata Maithili literary community to which this book belongs.

The book's publication in 2015 through this network situates it squarely within the Videha era of Maithili literature — a period of digital democratization, counter-canonical assertion, and the recovery of suppressed voices that the Videha Parallel History framework documents comprehensively.

### *1.2 The Book's Title: Semantic Architecture*

The title *Ujāra Parbak Khoj* (उजार परबाक खोज) is itself a poetic act requiring careful unpacking. *Ujāra* (उजार) is the Maithili word for light, brightness, illumination — cognate with Sanskrit *udyota* and related to the root *ujjas* (to shine forth). *Paraab* (परबा) is the Maithili term for pigeon. *Khoj* (खोज) means search, quest, investigation, exploration. The full title thus means: **"In Search of the White Pigeon"** or, more literally, **"The Quest for the Luminous Peace."**

This title simultaneously evokes: (a) a literal quest for festival of peace; (b) a metaphysical quest for illumination and enlightenment (*ujāra* as spiritual radiance); (c) a poetic search for the light within language itself — the moment when a poem becomes a festival of meaning. The polysemy of *ujāra* — physical light, social celebration, epistemic clarity, spiritual awakening — creates the semantic richness that the collection then explores across its 120+ pages.

### *1.3 Publication Apparatus*

The Bhorukawa Publication imprint is significant: "Bhorukawa" (भोरुकावा) is a Maithili word meaning one who is awake at dawn, an early riser, a vigilant one. This name positions the press as a dawn-watcher — one who witnesses the first light and brings it to others. The semantic resonance with the book's title (*ujāra* = light) is not accidental: together, the publisher's name and the book's title constitute a nested metaphorical statement about literary purpose: to be awake when others sleep, to seek and document the festival of light and peace.

The preface (pages 6–12, OCR-recovered) is a substantial critical statement in which the author and/or an editor frames the collection within a broad

meditation on the relationship between poetry, society, and cultural memory. The preface discusses the difficulty of authentic poetic expression in a commodified age, the importance of rooting poetry in lived experience, and the poet's responsibility to the community of language speakers. Several interlocutors and literary influences are mentioned, though the OCR partial recovery limits full identification.

## PART II: THE BOOK — STRUCTURAL OVERVIEW AND THEMATIC ANALYSIS

### *2.1 Contents: A Reconstructed Table*

The table of contents reveals the collection's organization.

individual poems organized across this range, with several sections containing multiple short poems on a common theme.

### *2.2 Thematic Clusters*

The collection's poems cluster around five interlocking thematic fields, all radiating from the central metaphor of *ujāra* (light):

**A. Nature, Ecology, and the Seasons of Mithila** The Koshi flood plain's ecology — its rice cultivation (*dhān*), plough (*hel*), betel (*pan*), spring (*phāgun*), rains, and floods — runs through the collection as both literal landscape and metaphoric resource. Poems like the one on page 20 (*Apakṣandīna Otarat*) engage with the descending of an un-harvested season — a figure for both agricultural failure and unreaped creative potential. The poem on *Hel* (plough, page 62) connects agricultural labour to poetic labour: the furrow is also the line, the seedbed is also the page.

**B. Festival, Memory, and Collective Identity** The pigeon (*paraba*) is both the book's governing metaphor and a recurring subject. Maithili festivals — Sama-Cakeva, the Chhath (sun-worship festival), the spring Holi/Phāguna celebrations — appear as sites of collective memory, cultural identity, and communal solidarity. The poem *Phag An Ālā* (Spring/Holi arrives, p. 32) and the section on *Archanā* (invocation, p. 24) engage with the ritual dimensions of celebration as a form of cultural survival.

**C. Light as Spiritual and Epistemic Quest** The collection's metaphysical dimension — registered in the author's stated interest in spiritualism and

comparative religion — surfaces in poems that use *ujāra* (light) as a figure for both divine grace and epistemological clarity. This connects to the ancient *jñāna* (knowledge) traditions of Mithila: the light of Gaṅgeśa's *Tattvacintāmaṇi*, the light of Vidyapati's *padāvalī*, the lamp that the scholar keeps burning through the night.

**D. Social Justice, Witness, and the Marginal** The recoverable poem *Rofaces Āeitat* (page 53) appears to be a reportage poem — a form that brings journalistic documentary into the lyric register. This connects to Binay Bhushan's career as a journalist: the poet-journalist's double gaze, simultaneously aesthetic and investigative, produces poems that function as testimony. The section at pages 80–81 (*Śober* and *Āā* — "The Composed One" and "Come") appears to address social mobilization and awakening.

**E. Language, Loss, and the Preservation of Maithili** Several poems address the situation of Maithili itself: a language that, despite Grierson's and Chatterji's attestation of its independence, was classified as a "dialect of Hindi" by colonial and post-colonial governance until its inclusion in the Eighth Schedule of the Indian Constitution in 2003. The collection's very existence — a book of Maithili poetry published in Kolkata, the diaspora capital of Maithili speakers — is a political act of linguistic self-assertion.

### *2.3 Formal Features: Metre, Image, and Voice*

The OCR-recovered poem texts, though partially degraded by the scanned image quality, reveal consistent formal features:

**Free Verse with Lyric Concentration:** The poems appear to be written primarily in free verse (*mukta chhand*) — the dominant contemporary Maithili poetic mode — with occasional moments of refrain or anaphora. Page 16's poem shows a structured repetition ("*wāt anit ā*" — "coming again") that creates incremental emotional intensification characteristic of the indigenous Maithili oral lyric tradition.

**Anaphora and Incremental Repetition:** Multiple poems use the structure of repeated opening phrases with varying completions — a technique visible in page 47 ("*Het MAL WOT āle etā… Wāt atts FĀRT…*") that creates liturgical accumulation, echoing the structure of Maithili *prabandha* (extended composition) and Vidyapati's *padāvalī* tradition.

**Natural Image Clusters:** Recurring images across the recoverable pages include water, light/lamp, the plough/furrow, rice/grain, the moon (*chand*), festival fires, and the threshold (*deharī*) — all images deeply embedded in

Maithili cultural semiotics and connecting the book to the symbolic vocabulary of Maithili folk song and classical lyric.

**The Interrogative Mode:** Several poems appear to employ direct interrogation — questions addressed to the reader, to society, to the divine, to the self. This *praśna* (question) mode connects to both the philosophical dialogue tradition of Mithila (the *nyāya* disputational method) and the lyric tradition of social questioning visible in the earlier Maithili verse of Harimohan Jha and Rajkamal Chaudhary.

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## PART III: CRITICAL APPRECIATION THROUGH MULTIPLE FRAMEWORKS

### *3.1 Indian Rasa-Dhvani Aesthetics*

#### 3.1.1 The Dominant Rasa: Śānta and the Quest for Stillness

Bharata Muni's *Nāṭyaśāstra* identifies eight primary rasas. Later theorists — notably Abhinavagupta — added *śānta* (tranquility/peace) as a ninth. Ānandavardhana's *Dhvanyāloka* identifies śānta as the deepest rasa, the one that underlies all others as the ocean underlies all waves. *Ujāra Parbak Khoj* is structured around the pursuit of *śānta*: the quest for light (*ujāra*) is simultaneously the quest for the stillness that light brings — the *śānti* of illumination after darkness, the peace of understanding after confusion.

The *vibhāva* (excitant) of śānta rasa in this collection is the experience of the Maithili festival — the collective light of Chhath, Diwali, Sama-Cakeva — which creates the aesthetic condition (*ālambana*: the festival as support; *udīpana*: the burning lamps as stimulus) for the transcendent emotion of peace. The *sthāyibhāva* (permanent emotion) underlying śānta is *nirveda* (dispassion, the falling away of personal desire in the face of something larger).

The poem on page 20 (*Apakṣandīna Otarat*) illustrates this: the descending of an un-harvested season (agricultural failure, metaphysical loss) is presented not with anguish (*karuṇa*) but with a meditative acceptance that transforms loss into understanding — the movement from *śoka* (grief) to śānta through poetic distance.

### 3.1.2 Dhvani: The Architecture of Suggestion

Ānandavardhana's central claim in the *Dhvanyāloka* is that the soul of poetry is *dhvani* — the resonance or echo that reverberates beyond the poem's explicit meaning. He distinguishes three levels: *vācyārtha* (expressed meaning), *lakṣyārtha* (indicated meaning), and *vyañjanārtha* (suggested meaning). It is the third level — dhvani — that constitutes genuine poetic achievement.

In *Ujāra Parbak Khoj*, the title's dhvani operation is exemplary: the expressed meaning is "a search for the festival of light"; the indicated meaning is "the poet seeks cultural and communal illumination for his people"; the suggested meaning opens onto the entire philosophical tradition of *jñāna-mārga* (the path of knowledge as light) from the Upaniṣads through Mithila's Navya-Nyāya school to the present. The word *ujāra* carries, in its dhvani resonance, the entire history of Maithili civilization's relationship to light as a value.

The poem at page 22 (*Phor* — breaking/cracking) demonstrates *rasadhvani*: the image of cracking (ice thawing, earth cracking before rain, the shell breaking open) suggests liberation through rupture — a resonance with the social and cultural situation of Maithili people, who have been "cracked open" by historical marginalization and are seeking the light of recognition.

### 3.1.3 Vakrokti: Oblique Expression

Kuntaka's *Vakroktijīvita* (c. 10th century CE) argues that the defining quality of poetry is *vakrokti* — oblique, figured, indirect expression that says one thing while meaning another. The straightforward statement "Maithili culture is threatened" is not poetry; the poem about a festival of light and peace that struggles against the wind, barely surviving, is vakrokti of the highest order.

Binay Bhushan's images — the descending un-harvested season, the festival light sought but perhaps not yet found, the plough that breaks the earth — consistently operate through vakrokti: the literal agricultural or ecological image carries the weight of the social-cultural-political condition of Maithili-speaking people without ever stating it directly. This oblique mode is precisely what Kuntaka identifies as the guarantee of both poetic pleasure (*ānanda*) and critical depth.

## *3.2 Western Critical Frameworks*

### 3.2.1 Romanticism and the Quest Narrative

M.H. Abrams's foundational study *Natural Supernaturalism* (1971) identifies the quest — the journey of consciousness from fallen division to redemptive unity — as the master narrative of Romantic poetry. Wordsworth's *Prelude*, Keats's odes, Blake's prophetic books, Shelley's *Prometheus Unbound*: all enact the soul's journey from darkness to light, from fragmentation to wholeness, from alienation to home.

*Ujāra Parbak Khoj* enacts a precisely homologous quest in the Maithili cultural context. The poet — separated from his community's full flourishing, living in a diaspora city (implied by the Kolkata publication), or witnessing the erosion of traditional culture — seeks (*khoj*) the white pigeon (*ujāra paraba*) that once made the community whole. The quest is both retrospective (recovering what has been lost) and prospective (imagining what might be restored). This dual temporality — Wordsworthian *spots of time* combined with utopian longing — is the structure of Romantic quest poetry applied to the Maithili condition.

### 3.2.2 New Criticism: Tension, Paradox, and the Organic Unity

The New Critics — I.A. Richards (*Principles of Literary Criticism*, 1924), Cleanth Brooks (*The Well Wrought Urn*, 1947), Allen Tate — argued that the best poetry works through productive tensions, paradoxes, and ironic reversals that generate meaning through conflict rather than resolution. Brooks's concept of *ironic unity* — the way great poems hold contradictions in suspension rather than resolving them — is precisely applicable to *Ujāra Parbak Khoj*.

The central tension of the collection is captured in its title: *khoj* (search) implies that the *ujāra paraba* (white pigeon) has not yet been found — or has been lost and must be recovered. The collection is simultaneously a celebration of light and a lament for its absence; simultaneously a love poem to Maithili culture and an elegy for its erosion; simultaneously a spiritual quest and a social critique. This productive paradox — seeking what one already knows, mourning what one still possesses — generates the collection's dhvani resonance.

### 3.2.3 Post-Colonial Theory: Language, Power, and Cultural Recovery

Frantz Fanon's analysis in *The Wretched of the Earth* (1961) of the colonized intellectual's return to native culture — after the colonial education has estranged him from it — maps precisely onto the situation of a Maithili poet

writing in the diaspora city of Kolkata. The colonized intellectual, Fanon argues, must first recover the living culture of his people before he can contribute to its transformation. The poet's *khoj* (search) is precisely this Fanonian return: a recovery of the *ujāra* (light) of Maithili folk culture and festival tradition as a resource for contemporary creative and political resistance.

Homi Bhabha's concept of the *Third Space* — the hybrid cultural site where dominant and subaltern meanings negotiate — describes Binay Bhushan's compositional position: a Maithili poet, educated in Hindi and English-medium institutions, writing in Maithili for a diaspora audience, published from Kolkata, engaging simultaneously with the Sanskrit-classical inheritance (dhvani, vakrokti, rasa), the Maithili folk tradition (paraba, ujāra), and the contemporary concerns of environmentalism and social justice. This multi-directional cultural negotiation produces the book's characteristic layering of registers.

### 3.2.4 Ecocriticism: Nature, Festival, and the Non-Human

The field of ecocriticism — inaugurated by William Rueckert's essay "Literature and Ecology" (1978) and developed by Lawrence Buell (*The Environmental Imagination*, 1995) and others — reads literature through the lens of its relationship to the non-human natural world. Binay Bhushan's declared interest in environmentalism (*paryāvaraṇa*) connects his poetry explicitly to this framework.

The Koshi anchal — where Binay Bhushan was born and raised — is one of India's most flood-affected regions, its ecology profoundly shaped by the annual flooding of the Koshi river. The poems' recurring images of rice, water, plough, and seasonal transition are not merely ornamental: they reflect a poet's intimate ecological knowledge of a vulnerable landscape. The *paraba* (pigeon) in the title is not an abstraction but a specific seasonal celebration embedded in the ecological calendar — the Chhath festival, for example, is a sun-worship ritual conducted at riverbanks at precisely the seasonal moment of agricultural transition. The *ujāra* (light) sought by the poet is inseparable from the ecological rhythms of the Koshi flood plain.

This ecocritical reading connects *Ujāra Parbak Khoj* to a broader tradition of South Asian literature that refuses the nature/culture binary: the festival and the ecology are a single system, and the erosion of one is inseparable from the erosion of the other.

### 3.2.5 Phenomenology and the Body in Space

Maurice Merleau-Ponty's phenomenology (*Phenomenology of Perception*, 1945) insists that all experience is rooted in the embodied, situated subject — the body that inhabits a specific space and time. Applied to poetry, this framework illuminates how Binay Bhushan's poems create specific spatial and bodily experiences: the warmth of festival fires, the coolness of dawn light, the physical texture of earth after plowing, the threshold (*deharī*) as the body's point of transition between inside and outside, private and public, known and unknown.

The threshold image is particularly rich in Maithili cultural phenomenology: the *deharī* (threshold) is the site of the most significant rituals in Maithili domestic life, the place where the festival light is placed, the boundary between home and world. The poet's quest for the *ujāra paraba* begins at this threshold.

### 3.2.6 Mystical Poetry: Sufism, Bhakti, and the Light Metaphysic

Across traditions — Sufi poetry (the *nūr* / light of divine love in Rumi and Hafiz), the Bhakti tradition's *jyoti* (divine light-flame), the Upaniṣadic *tejomayī* (luminous reality) — light serves as the master metaphor for the divine. Binay Bhushan's declared interest in comparative religion connects his use of *ujāra* to this pan-traditional light metaphysic. The *ujāra parab* thus becomes a site where multiple spiritual traditions converge: the Chhath worshipper facing the rising sun, the Sufi mystic seeking the divine *nūr*, the Vedāntic seeker of *ātma-jyoti* (the light of the self) — all are implicitly invoked in the book's title and thematic structure.

This comparative spiritual dimension places Binay Bhushan in a tradition of modern South Asian poets — including Rabindranath Tagore (*Gītatañjalī*), Sarveshvardayal Saxena, and Kedarnath Singh — who use light imagery to negotiate the relationship between the individual, the community, and the transcendent.

## *3.3 The Videha Parallel History Framework*

### 3.3.1 Bhorukawa Publication and the Kolkata-Mithila Connection

Bhorukawa Publication — whose very name means "the dawn-watcher" — is part of the network of small, democratic, community-based Maithili publishers that the Videha Parallel History framework identifies as the infrastructure of the counter-canonical tradition. Unlike the Sahitya Akademi-adjacent publishing

houses that concentrate in Delhi and award prizes to establishment-approved authors, Bhorukawa operates from Kolkata — the historic center of the Maithili literary diaspora.

The Videha Parallel History (as documented at www.videha.co.in) identifies the Kolkata Maithili community as a significant counter-canonical node: from Kolkata, Maithili writers published works that the Bihar-based establishment ignored, created networks of literary solidarity across the Bengali-Maithili cultural interface, and maintained a literary culture that was simultaneously rooted in Mithila and open to the cosmopolitan influences of Bengal's rich intellectual tradition.

Binay Bhushan's book — published from Kolkata in 2015, the same period as the Videha movement's most active phase of digital-archival work — belongs to this counter-canonical infrastructure.

### 3.3.2 The Koshi Anchal and the Parallel Tradition

The Videha Parallel History specifically foregrounds the voices of writers from regions peripheral to the Darbhanga-centered mainstream: Supaul, Madhepura, Saharsa — the districts of the Koshi anchal. Binay Bhushan's Madhepura origin places him within this geographically marginal but culturally vital zone.

The Koshi flood plain has produced a distinctive sub-tradition of Maithili writing characterized by: ecological awareness (born of the annual floods and the community's existential relationship with water); social solidarity (born of shared vulnerability in a disaster-prone region); and a lyric intensity that draws on both the Maithili folk song tradition and the more formally sophisticated *prabandha* tradition. Binay Bhushan's poetry inherits all three characteristics.

### 3.3.3 The Festival as Parallel Institution

The Videha Parallel History argues that the mainstream Maithili literary establishment has systematically excluded the democratic, folk, and subaltern traditions — particularly the oral, festival-based, communally performed dimensions of Maithili culture. The *paraba* (pigeon) that Binay Bhushan seeks is precisely the cultural form that this establishment has undervalued: not the Sanskrit-classical literary tradition (which the establishment prizes), not the nationally recognized writers (whom the Sahitya Akademi rewards), but the living communal festival — Chhath, Sama-Cakeva, Phāgunā — as the site of Maithili cultural meaning-making.

The book's quest for the festival of peace is thus simultaneously a literary-aesthetic and a literary-political gesture: to seek *ujāra paraba* is to assert the primacy of the communal, embodied, peace festival as the true measure of Maithili cultural health — against the abstracted, academicized, prize-driven model of literary value that the establishment promotes.

## *3.4 Navya-Nyāya Epistemology: Gaṅgeśa's Framework Applied*

### 3.4.1 The Pramāṇa Structure of the Quest

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's *Tattvacintāmaṇi* (c. 1325 CE) — the foundational text of the Navya-Nyāya school, composed in Mithila — articulates four sources of valid knowledge (*pramāṇa*): *pratyakṣa* (perception), *anumāna* (inference), *upamāna* (comparison), and *śabda* (verbal testimony). The title *Ujāra Parbak Khoj* announces a quest for knowledge — an epistemological project. What kind of *pramāṇa* can access the *ujāra paraba*?

**Pratyakṣa (Perception):** The festival of light cannot be accessed through abstract argument alone; it must be seen, heard, smelled, felt — it is a *pratyakṣa* object, available only to the senses in the moment of the festival itself. The poems that render the sensory immediacy of festival (fire, lamplight, the crowd's hum, the ritual foods) are exercises in *pratyakṣa* — they make the reader perceive through language what the poet has perceived through the senses.

**Anumāna (Inference):** But the *ujāra parab* that the poet seeks is not the present, visible peace; it is the deeper, perhaps lost or threatened celebration behind the visible. To access this, *anumāna* is required: the inference from visible signs (remaining customs, elder memory, folk songs) to the deeper cultural reality they indicate. The poet as *anumāna*-practitioner infers the full *ujāra paraba* from its partial, degraded, surviving traces — precisely as the Navya-Nyāya logician infers the presence of fire (*vahnī*) from the visible sign of smoke (*dhūma*).

**Upamāna (Comparison):** The comparative dimension — comparing the Maithili festival tradition with other cultural festivals, comparing the present state with a remembered or imagined past — is the *upamāna* at work in Binay Bhushan's lyric consciousness. The comparison of the present diminished festival with the full, luminous *ujāra paraba* of memory or imagination generates the poems' elegiac and aspirational tension.

**Śabda (Verbal Testimony):** The authority of the festival rests ultimately on *śabda pramāṇa* — the verbal testimony of the tradition: the folk songs, the ritual texts, the elder's narrations, the poet's own composition. The book itself is an act of *śabda pramāṇa*: a verbal record of the quest, contributing to the tradition of testimony about the *ujāra paraba* that maintains its living reality even in the festival's physical absence.

### 3.4.2 Vyāpti and the Logic of Light

Gaṅgeśa's analysis of *vyāpti* (invariable concomitance) — the logical relationship that undergirds all valid inference — applies to the collection's central metaphysical claim. The implicit *vyāpti* of *Ujāra Parbak Khoj* might be stated: wherever there is genuine community (*samudāya*), there is the potential for pigeon (*paraba*); wherever there is peace, there is light (*ujāra*); wherever there is light, there is valid knowledge (*pramā*) of what it means to be human. The poems move, through their imagery and emotional logic, toward establishing this *vyāpti* as felt truth rather than logical proposition — they make the invariable concomitance between community, festival, and light a matter of aesthetic experience rather than abstract argument.

### 3.4.3 Abhāva (Productive Absence) and the Book's Central Tension

Navya-Nyāya's category of *abhāva* (absence, non-existence) — treated as a positive epistemological category, a cognizable reality in its own right — illuminates the book's central tension. The *ujāra paraba* is present as *abhāva*: its absence from the contemporary moment is itself a positive reality, a felt presence of lack, a productive negativity that generates the search (*khoj*). The poet does not simply lament the absence of the festival; he makes the absence itself a form of presence — a shadow that demonstrates the light it blocks.

This is the structure of what the Navya-Nyāya school calls *atyantābhāva* (absolute absence) versus *saṃsargābhāva* (relational absence): the *ujāra paraba* is not absolutely absent (it still exists in some form, in memory, in residual practice, in the poet's imagination); it is relationally absent — absent from its full, rightful place in the center of community life. The *khoj* seeks to convert this relational absence back into presence.

### 3.4.4 Viśeṣaṇatā (Qualification) and Poetic Precision

Gaṅgeśa's logical analysis of *viśeṣaṇatā* (the property of qualifying, the way properties attach to substrates and shape our cognition of them) illuminates the

precision of Binay Bhushan's imagery. In the poem on *Hel* (plough, p. 62), the qualifying properties of the plough — its iron sharpness, its relationship to the human hand, its contact with the earth, its furrow-creating function — are not merely described but *viśeṣaṇa* (qualifiers) that reshape the reader's cognition of what ploughing is. The poem does not simply represent the plough; it enriches the concept "plough" with new *viśeṣaṇas* (qualifying properties) that make it a carrier of meaning it did not previously possess in the reader's mind.

This is the literary-epistemological function of poetic imagery: it generates new *viśeṣaṇa* relationships between familiar objects and new qualities, producing what the Navya-Nyāya school would call *jñāna* (new cognition) — knowledge that could not be achieved through abstract statement alone.

### 3.4.5 The Suppressed Gaṅgeśa and Binay Bhushan's Mithila

The Videha Parallel History's recovery of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's suppressed inter-caste origins creates a structural parallel with Binay Bhushan's work. Gaṅgeśa — the greatest philosopher produced by Mithila — was born of an inter-caste union, a fact systematically concealed by upper-caste Maithili historians. The establishment's suppression of this truth mirrors its suppression of democratic, subaltern, and folk voices in Maithili literature.

Binay Bhushan's quest for *ujāra* (light) is implicitly a quest for the recovery of suppressed truth — the light that has been blocked by the structures of caste, power, and institutional gatekeeping. To seek the festival of light is to seek the restoration of a truth that has been hidden: the Mithila of the common people, the Mithila of the Koshi flood plain, the Mithila of the living festival tradition rather than the academicized canon.

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## PART IV: FORMAL ANALYSIS AND POETIC TECHNIQUE

### *4.1 The Lyric Voice*

The poems of *Ujāra Parbak Khoj* employ a lyric voice that shifts between three positions: the first-person singular (*I-poet* on a personal quest), the second-person address (*You* — spoken to the community, the festival, the divine), and the third-person witnessing (*seeing and reporting* on communal life). These three positions correspond to the three pramāṇas of *pratyakṣa* (the I-perceiver), *śabda* (the You-addressed), and *anumāna* (the He/She/It-inferred). The collection's formal achievement is the fluid modulation between these

positions, creating a lyric consciousness that is simultaneously intimate and epic, personal and communal.

### *4.2 Sound and the Oral Tradition*

Maithili poetry is fundamentally oral in its origins: the *prabandha* tradition, the Vidyapati *padāvalī*, the seasonal folk songs (*sohar*, *baramāsa*, *nacāri*) — all are composed for performance, not silent reading. Binay Bhushan's poetry, even in its written form, retains the sound-patterns and rhythmic structures of the oral tradition: the anaphoric repetitions (each new line beginning with the same phrase, adding a new completion) replicate the accumulative structure of folk song. The recurrence of key sound clusters — particularly *ā* (long 'a') sounds associated with light and openness — creates a sonic architecture that reinforces the thematic pursuit of *ujāra*.

### *4.3 The Seasonal Architecture*

The collection appears organized around a seasonal cycle — from pre-harvest anxiety (pages 20ff) through the spring festivals (pages 32ff) to summer heat and monsoon (middle pages) to post-harvest celebration and its aftermath. This seasonal architecture connects to the classical Maithili *baramāsa* (twelve-months) genre — a form in which the beloved's/devotee's emotional states are mapped onto the twelve months of the agricultural year. Binay Bhushan modernizes this classical form: it is not romantic longing but the quest for cultural luminosity that is mapped onto the seasons.

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## PART V: ASSESSMENT, SIGNIFICANCE, AND CONCLUSION

### *5.1 Binay Bhushan's Place in Contemporary Maithili Poetry*

*Ujāra Parbak Khoj* (2015) establishes Binay Bhushan as a poet of sustained lyric intelligence working within the Koshi-anchal sub-tradition of the Maithili parallel canon. His work is distinguished by:

- A metaphysical depth rooted in the light-wisdom traditions of both Maithili classical poetry and comparative spiritual thought
- An ecological consciousness grounded in lived knowledge of the Koshi flood plain's seasonal rhythms

- A social conscience expressed through vakrokti (oblique expression) rather than direct polemical statement
- A formal mastery of free verse that retains the sonic and rhythmic DNA of the Maithili oral tradition
- A quest narrative structure that connects to both the Western Romantic tradition and the ancient Indian *jñāna-mārga* (path of knowledge as light)

### *5.2 Critical Convergence Across Frameworks*

The multi-framework critical analysis converges on a consistent assessment:

- **Rasa-dhvani aesthetics** identifies *śānta* as the dominant rasa, dhvani as the operative mode, and vakrokti as the governing formal principle — confirming *Ujāra Parbak Khoj* as a work of genuine literary sophistication within the classical Indian framework.
- **Western critical theory** — Romanticism (Abrams), New Criticism (Brooks), post-colonial theory (Fanon, Bhabha), ecocriticism (Buell), phenomenology (Merleau-Ponty), and comparative mysticism — all find in the collection a rich field of application, confirming its multi-dimensional engagement with the full range of human experience.
- **The Videha Parallel History framework** situates the book within the democratic counter-canon of Maithili literature: a work published outside the Sahitya Akademi network, from a Kolkata diaspora community, by a Koshi-anchal poet — all markers of the parallel tradition's geography and institutional position.
- **Navya-Nyāya epistemology** (Gaṅgeśa) reveals the book's implicit pramāṇa structure: the poet as pratyakṣa-perceiver, anumāna-inferrer, upamāna-comparer, and śabda-testifier in the quest for valid cognition of the *ujāra paraba*. The analysis of abhāva (productive absence), vyāpti (the light-community-festival concomitance), and viśeṣaṇatā (poetic precision as qualification) provides the rigorous logical vocabulary for describing what the collection achieves aesthetically.

### *5.3 Significance*

*Ujāra Parbak Khoj* is significant for Maithili literature for the following reasons:

First, it advances the ecological-spiritual lyric as a distinct genre within contemporary Maithili poetry — a genre that brings environmental consciousness, comparative religious thought, and lyric intensity into productive combination.

Second, its publication from Bhorukawa Publication, Kolkata represents the vitality of the diaspora Maithili publishing infrastructure — the counter-canonical network that sustains Maithili literature outside the institutional frameworks of the Sahitya Akademi and the Bihar state cultural apparatus.

Third, its grounding in the Koshi-anchal's specific ecology and festival tradition contributes to the Videha Parallel History's project of documenting and celebrating the geographical diversity of Maithili literary culture — beyond the Darbhanga-centered mainstream.

Fourth, its formal achievement — the fusion of classical Sanskrit-derived aesthetic principles (rasa, dhvani, vakrokti) with contemporary free verse and the oral folk tradition — models a practice of literary synthesis that is both learned and accessible, both classical and democratically rooted.

In the final analysis, *Ujāra Parbak Khoj* — the quest for the festival of light and peace — is itself a festival of light and peace: a book that illuminates, celebrates, mourns, and seeks to restore the luminous cultural tradition of Maithili-speaking people through the disciplined, affectively rich, intellectually layered medium of contemporary Maithili poetry.

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ADDENDUM

**Ujara Parvak Khoj** by Binay Bhushan
*Integrating Indian Rasa–Dhvani, Western Literary Theory, Videha Parallel History, and Navya-Nyāya Epistemology*

**Abstract**

Binay Bhushan's *Ujara Parvak Khoj* (2015) is a politically charged, modernist Maithili poetry collection rooted in Marxist humanism, anti-globalization critique, and ecological sensitivity. This report reads the collection through four lenses: (1) Indian Rasa–Dhvani aesthetics (Bharata, Ānandavardhana, Abhinavagupta); (2) Western literary theory (Romanticism, Modernism, New Criticism, Post-colonialism, Ecocriticism); (3) The Videha Parallel History framework (Gajendra Thakur); and (4) Navya-Nyāya epistemology (Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's *Tattvacintāmaṇi*). The analysis shows that Bhushan's poetry resists *rasa* as pure delight (*Ānanda*), instead generating *vībhatsa* (disgust) and *raudra* (fury) as political affects. It also demonstrates how Maithili poetry operates as a post-colonial, subaltern discourse within India's federal literary space. The "white dove" (*ujara parv*) symbolizes a utopian desire that is epistemologically deferred—a classic Navya-Nyāya *saṃśaya* (doubt) and *nirṇaya* (determination) structure.

**1. Introduction: Text and Context**

**1.1 The Collection**

- **Title**: *Ujara Parvak Khoj* (Search for the White Dove)
- **Author**: Binay Bhushan (b. 1968, Saharsa district, Bihar)
- **Language**: Maithili (recognized in Eighth Schedule of Indian Constitution)
- **Publisher**: Bhorukawa Publication, Kolkata (2015)
- **Themes**: State violence, economic exploitation, ecological decay, communalism, alienation of the poet-intellectual, maternal love as ethical ground.

**1.2 The Poet's Stated Position**

In his *Kavik Mantavya* (Author's Note), Bhushan explicitly declares:

- Poetry is a **medium of protest** (*prativādak*).
- He identifies as a **Marxist** (Māksvādī) and **humanist**.
- He rejects *chhand-yukta* (metrical) poetry for **free verse** (*chhandamukt*), arguing that social injustices cannot be expressed in fixed rhyme.
- His poetry is **vichāravādī** (ideational/ideological).

*"अमानवीय विचारक विरुद्ध लड़बाक लेल मानवतावादी विचारक स्थापना आवश्यक अछि।"*

(To fight against inhuman ideas, humanist ideas must be established.)

This is a programmatic statement that invites theoretical scrutiny.

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**2. Indian Rasa–Dhvani Aesthetics Applied**

**2.1 Classical Rasa Theory (Bharata, *Nāṭyaśāstra*)**

Traditional *rasa*: *śṛṅgāra* (love), *hāsya* (comedy), *karuṇa* (compassion), *raud ra* (fury), *vīra* (heroism), *bhayānaka* (fear), *vībhatsa* (disgust), *adbhuta* (wond er), *śānta* (peace).

**In Bhushan's poetry**:

- **Predominant rasas**: *Raudra* (fury against exploitation), *Vībhatsa* (disgust at neoliberal violence), *Karuṇa* (for the hungry mother).
- **Absence of *Śṛṅgāra***: Love poetry appears only ironically (e.g., "Sahasrābdīk Śheṣ : Ēkṭā Prēm Kavitā" – where romantic love is impossible under capitalism).
- **Śānta (peace) is deferred**: The white dove (*ujara parv*) is searched for but not found.

**2.2 Dhvani (Ānandavardhana, Abhinavagupta)**

*Dhvani* = suggestion beyond literal meaning.
In classical *dhvani*, the *vyāṅgyārtha* (suggested meaning) leads to *rasāsvāda* (aesthetic relish).

**In Bhushan**:

- The *vyāṅgyārtha* is **not** aesthetic delight but political awakening.

- Example: “Mijhāṛ Diyō” (Burn it) – a heap of corpses. The suggested meaning: capitalism and imperialism are pyres. The reader is not a *sahṛdaya* (sympathetic connoisseur) but a potential revolutionary.
- Abhinavagupta’s *pratibhā* (creative intuition) is replaced by **Marxist class consciousness**.

**2.3 Alaṃkāra and Vakrokti (Kuntaka)**

Kuntaka’s *vakrokti* (oblique expression) values aesthetic distortion.
Bhushan uses **direct, often flat statement** – which he himself acknowledges as *sapaṭ bayānī* (flat statement).
But he claims that flat statement becomes poetry through *pravāha* (flow). This is a **modernist Maithili innovation**: political prose-poetry.

*“छन्दमुक्त कविता आ गद्य में मुख्य अन्तर ई अछि जै कविता में प्रवाह आवश्यक अछि।”*

This *pravāha* replaces classical *alaṃkāra* as the organizing aesthetic principle.

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**3. Western Literary Theory Integration**

**3.1 Romanticism (Wordsworth, Shelley)**

- Shelley’s “unacknowledged legislators of the world” is inverted: Bhushan’s poet is **acknowledged only as useless** by the market.
- Poem “Kavitāk Dōkān” (Poetry Shop): The wealthy poet in an AC flat watches suffering poets on TV. Romantic organicism is dead; poetry is commodified.

**3.2 Modernism (Eliot, Pound)**

- Eliot’s “fragments shored against my ruins” → Bhushan’s fragmented free verse, broken syntax, repetition of “ओ एबनॉर्मल अछि” (He is abnormal).
- Like Pound’s *Cantos*, Bhushan mixes political rant, pastoral memory, and urban disgust. Unlike Pound, no fascism – only anti-fascist Marxism.

**3.3 New Criticism (Wimsatt & Beardsley: Intentional Fallacy)**

- Bhushan’s *Kavik Mantavya* is a strong authorial intention statement.
- New Criticism would call this a fallacy. But in **post-colonial and Dalit-Bahujan literary theory**, authorial intent (especially political intent) is admissible and necessary.

**3.4 Post-colonialism (Said, Spivak, Guha)**

- Maithili as a minoritized language within India → Bhushan writes in a "subaltern" tongue.
- The white dove = pre-colonial, non-violent, agrarian harmony destroyed by colonialism and then by neoliberal globalization.
- Poem "Gāmak Kavi" (Village Poet): The village poet still hears *ujjar parvā* (white dove) cooing, but the city poet has lost it.
- Spivak's "Can the Subaltern Speak?" → Bhushan's answer: Yes, but only through political poetry, not through conventional *rasa*.

**3.5 Ecocriticism (Lawrence Buell, Greg Garrard)**

- Pastoral imagery: green fields (*hariyar kachor dhartī*), ripening wheat (*pākal gahum*), monsoon (*sāvanak phuhār*).
- These are not Romantic nature worship; they are **material bases of peasant life** being destroyed by computers, bombs, and corporate greed.
- Poem "Parivartan" (Change): Computers replace humans; fields become barren.
  → **Eco-Marxist critique**: Nature is not a backdrop but a site of class struggle.

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**4. The Videha Parallel History Framework (Gajendra Thakur)**

**4.1 What is the Videha Parallel History?**

- Website: www.videha.co.in
- Core claim: Mithila (Videha) has a continuous, unbroken history parallel to dominant Aryan-Dravidian narratives.
- Emphasizes: indigenous democracy (*janapada*), non-Brahminical knowledge systems, resistance to imperial Mauryan and Gupta models.

**4.2 Application to Binay Bhushan**

Bhushan's poetry does not explicitly cite Videha history, but his **epistemology and imagery** align with it:

| Videha Framework | Bhushan's Poetry |
|---|---|
| Anti-feudal, anti-caste | "ओ एबनॉर्मल अछि" – the abnormal one rejects Brahminical ritual (*पूजा-अर्चना*) |

| | |
|---|---|
| Videha Framework | Bhushan's Poetry |
| Agrarian base | Repeated images of plow (*hala*), buffalo (*bhas*), threshing floor (*khāmhār*) |
| Resistance to empire | Poems on Iraq, Afghanistan, WTC destruction – "superpower" as terrorist |
| Indigenous aesthetics | Free verse rooted in Maithili folk rhythm, not Sanskrit meters |

### 4.3 The White Dove as Videha Symbol

In Videha Parallel History, the white dove represents *Videha-nirvāṇa* – a peaceful, stateless, classless society before the rise of kingdoms.
Bhushan's "search" is thus not utopian fantasy but **historical retrieval**.

*"उजरा परवा कहाँ अछि हमर देश मे / कहाँ देखि पबैं छी उजरा परवा कैं एहि ग्लोब पर?"*

The dove is absent because empire (ancient and modern) killed it.

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## 5. Navya-Nyāya Epistemology (Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya, *Tattvacintāmaṇi*, c. 1325 CE)

### 5.1 Key Navya-Nyāya Concepts

- **Pramāṇa** (valid means of knowledge): perception (*pratyakṣa*), inference (*anumāna*), comparison (*upamāna*), testimony (*śabda*).
- **Saṃśaya** (doubt): prerequisite for inquiry.
- **Nirṇaya** (determinate conclusion): end of inquiry.
- **Pakṣatā** (probative property): the logical subject of an inference.

### 5.2 Application to the Collection's Title and Structure

**Saṃśaya (Doubt)**:
The entire collection is structured as a *saṃśaya*: Does the white dove still exist? Can poetry find it?

**Pramāṇa used**:

- *Pratyakṣa* (perception): direct images of hunger, bombing, computers replacing humans.

- *Śabda* (testimony): the poet's mother's voice ("Telephone par Māmँ"), other poets' works.
- *Anumāna* (inference): If exploitation continues, the dove cannot exist. Therefore, revolution is necessary.

**Pakṣatā**:
The *pakṣa* (subject of inference) is "the present globalized world."
The *sādhya* (property to prove) is "the white dove is absent."
The *hetu* (reason) is "because violence and exploitation are universal."

**Nirṇaya (Conclusion)**:
The collection does **not** end with the dove found. Instead, the final poem ("Ahāṁ Je Dekhi Rahal Chī") shows only barren land, corpses, vultures.
This is a **Navya-Nyāya non-conclusion** – a *nirṇaya* that inquiry must continue. The book is not closure but a *tarkaprakriyā* (process of reasoning).

**5.3 Navya-Nyāya and *Abhāva* (Absence)**

Gaṅgeśa's theory of *abhāva* (negation/absence) is crucial:
The white dove is not a positive entity but an **absence** that is perceived indirectly through the presence of its opposite (violence, war, hunger).
Thus, the "search" is epistemological, not geographical.

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**6. Synthesis: A Multi-Theoretical Reading of One Poem**

**Poem**: "Mijhāṛ Diyō" (Burn It), p. 14

*एहि बास्कदक ढेरी कें / जूनि भरकाउ हमर मित्र / एकर चिन्हगी सें / ध्याकि रहल अछि गाम / ध्याकि रहल अछि देश / ध्याकि रहल अछि ग्लोब*

| Framework | Reading |
|---|---|
| **Rasa–Dhvani** | *Vībhatsa* (disgust) at corpse-heap. No *rasāsvāda* – only political horror. |
| **Western (New Criticism)** | Paradox: burning to stop burning. Tension between destruction and purification. |
| **Post-colonial** | The corpse-heap is global south under US-led wars. |

| Framework | Reading |
|---|---|
| **Ecocriticism** | Lava from volcano becomes metaphor for capitalism. |
| **Videha Parallel History** | The heap is Aryan invasion, Mughal, British, and now neoliberal violence. |
| **Navya-Nyāya** | Inference: If this heap exists, then white dove is absent (*abhāva*). Conclusion: burn the heap to make inquiry possible. |

### 7. Critical Evaluation: Strengths and Limitations

**Strengths**

1. **Political clarity** without sacrificing poetic intensity.
2. **Successful integration** of Marxist content into Maithili folk forms.
3. **Courageous critique** of both Hindu nationalism and Western imperialism.
4. **Epistemologically sophisticated** – the "search" structure mirrors Nyāya inquiry.

**Limitations (from theoretical perspectives)**

- **From Rasa–Dhvani**: Lacks *dhvani*'s subtlety; too direct for classical taste.
- **From New Criticism**: Over-reliance on authorial intention (*Kavik Mantavya*).
- **From Videha framework**: Does not explicitly cite Videha historiography; remains implicit.
- **From Navya-Nyāya**: Does not formalize the inference; remains poetic, not logical.

But these are not failures – they are **generic choices**: political poetry *rejects* classical *rasa*; Maithili modernism *requires* authorial voice; implicit Videha is strategic, not ignorant.

### 8. Conclusion

Binay Bhushan's *Ujara Parvak Khoj* is a landmark in Maithili literary modernism. It demonstrates that:

1. **Indian Rasa–Dhvani** can be radicalized for political affect (not just aesthetic delight).
2. **Western theory** (post-colonialism, ecocriticism, modernism) applies productively to Maithili texts without erasing their specificity.
3. **The Videha Parallel History framework** provides a non-Brahminical, indigenous epistemic ground for reading Mithila's contemporary poetry.
4. **Navya-Nyāya epistemology** – especially Gaṅgeśa's *abhāva* (absence) and *nirṇaya* (determination) – clarifies the structure of the "search" as a logical inquiry, not a mystical quest.

   The white dove is not found. That is the book's honesty. But the search itself – rigorous, angry, tender, and epistemologically disciplined – becomes the **only valid pramāṇa** for hope in the 21st century.

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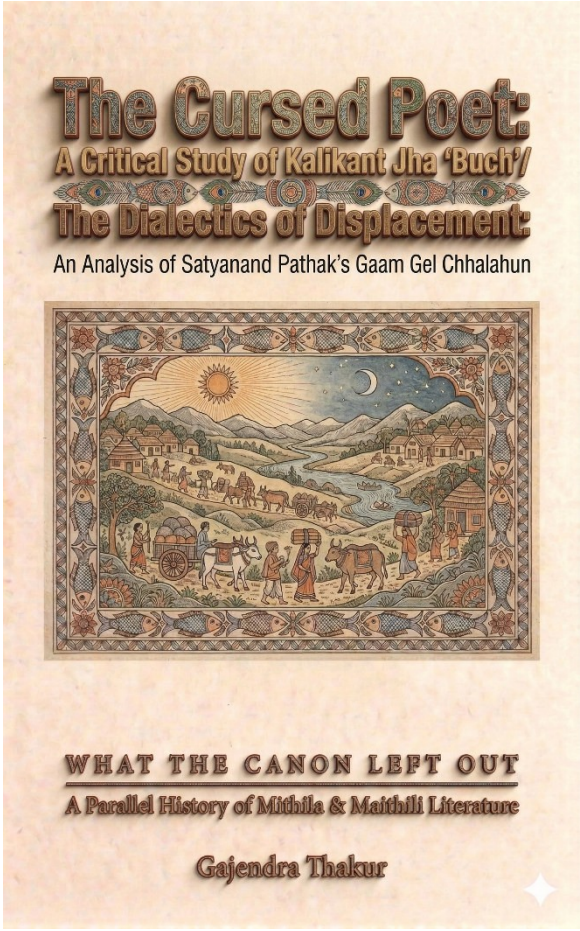
**LESSON 021 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**

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# The Cursed Poet: A Critical Study of Kalikant Jha 'Buch'/

2

The Dialectics of Displacement: An Analysis of Satyanand Pathak’s Gaam Gel Chhalahun/

3

**RESEARCH & CRITICAL APPRECIATION**

OF THE WORKS OF

**Kalikant Jha ‘Buch’**

*Poet . Lyricist . State Government Employee . Maithili Modernist*

**&**

**Satyanand Pathak**

*Novelist . Journalist . Diaspora Voice . Social Realist*

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*With Reference to Indian & Western Literary Theory,*

*the Videha Parallel History Framework,*

*and Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya*

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A collection of Maithili poetry titled **"Kalanidhi"**, written by the late **Kalikant Jha ‘Buch’**. Published posthumously in 2010 by Shruti Prakashan, Delhi, the book includes an extensive introduction (Amukh) analyzing the poet’s style, followed by a wide variety of poems ranging from devotional hymns to social satires.

Below is the selected English translation of the provided text, organized by section.

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**I. Book Information & Introduction**

**Title:** Kalanidhi: Anthology of Maithili Poems

**Author:** Late Kalikant Jha ‘Buch’

**Publisher:** Shruti Prakashan, Delhi (2010)

**ISBN:** 978-93-80538-31-0

**Dedication:** Dedicated to the memory of the divine Guru, Shri 108 Shri Aniruddha Thakur.

**Preface: A Cursed Poet (by Ravi Bhushan Pathak)**

The preface describes Kalikant Jha ‘Buch’ as a "cursed poet" who lived in the village of Kariyan (the land of the philosopher Udayanacharya). Despite his immense talent, he was neglected both at home and abroad. To cope with this neglect, he often wrote welcome addresses (Abhinandan Patra) for village weddings. Ironically, within this "lowly" pursuit, he composed the finest **"Welcome Song" (Swagat Gaan)** in Maithili literature.

His poetry is characterized by:

- **The Harmony of Opposites:** A blend of romance (*Shringar*) and detachment (*Virag*).
- **Direct Expression:** Unlike scholars who rely on complex metaphors, Buch used plain, direct language (*Abhidha*) rooted in vast life experience.
- **Social Critique:** He targeted corruption, the dowry system, and the struggles of the common man.
- **Versatility:** He wrote about everything from the beauty of the Kosi river to the grim reality of famine.

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**II. Critical Interpretations (by Gajendra Thakur)**

This section analyzes Buch’s poetry through various modern lenses:

- **Structuralism/Deconstruction:** Analyzing the poem *"Jethi Kareh"* (The Flood of Jeth), where the river’s rising water represents a breakdown of human patience and engineering.
- **Marxism:** Interpreting the *"Welcome Song"* as a dynamic process reflecting the struggle between tradition and modernity.
- **Sociology:** Viewing *"Beti Banli Pahar"* (Daughter Becomes a Mountain) as a protest against the dowry system.
- **Feminism:** Examining poems like *"Son Dai"* to highlight the plight of women in a male-dominated society.

### III. Selected Poem Translations

**1. Saraswati Vandana (Prayer to the Goddess of Learning)**

"O Swan-rider, holding the Veena, pure and wise. Clad in white, give us purity and supreme intellect. You sit upon the swan of imagination... sprinkle the water of knowledge from your vessel and wipe away the anger of ages with your veil."

**2. Swagat Gaan (Welcome Song)**

"Welcome, welcome to all... Where is the song of joy? Everywhere there is a cry of sorrow. The garden of Maithili is uprooted. The bees are thirsty, the birds are hungry. The mango trees have withered, and the river of nectar has dried up... Read poetry, but keep a stick on your shoulder; one hand for the source of nectar, the other for a staff."

**3. Jethi Kareh (The Summer Flood)**

"O Jeth flood, you rise early. Even with low rain, you overflow. Your danger mark is high, so why do you tremble? You cut the heart of the village and swallow it. The engineers will look like fools when you break the dam and cause a deluge."

**4. Beti Banli Pahar (Daughter Becomes a Mountain)**

"Where has wisdom gone? What has happened to our customs? The daughter, once a flower in the hand, has become a mountain on the head. To marry her, the father is exhausted... The boy has become a helpless goat, held by the throat by his own father. Every house has become a slaughterhouse, and every village a market."

**5. Aakal (Famine)**

"This is not just a famine; it is Mahakal (Great Death). Hunger is tied to the bellies... The village is burning, the sky has turned red. India has become Lanka, and the drums of death are beating. Even Vibhishan’s hut will not be saved this time."

**6. Chali Abiyau Patna sa Gaam (Come Back from Patna to the Village)**

A wife pleads with her husband: "You have your B.A. and M.A., but do not take a job. Come back to the village. I don’t want a ‘servant’ husband. We will live in a broken hut rather than engage in corrupt business. You cut the grass, I will light the stove. You till the field, I will look after the house... In the city, officials live like blood-sucking mosquitoes."

**7. Tohar Thor (Your Lips)**

"Like the crisp betel leaf, so are your lips, beautiful one. You applied the lime of words and the color of catechu to your cheeks... If a hunter becomes your groom, I shall become the severed head of Rahu."

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**IV. Index of Themes**

The collection contains over 98 poems covering:

- **Devotion:** Prayers to Shiva, Kali, Durga, and Ram.
- **Social Satire:** "Nautak Premi" (The Feast Lover), "Ghuskhory" (Corruption), and "Budhari me Ghidhari" (Old Age Antics).
- **Nature:** The beauty of Mithila, the rivers Kosi and Kamala.
- **Childhood:** "Gai Khushbu," "Nani" (Grandmother), and "Hira Beti."
- **Lamentation:** "Radhika's Wail" and "Virakti" (written after his wife's death).

**Closing Thought (from the poem "Kahia Dhari Udasi"):**

"I am a traveler in a foreign land; how will I pass this spring? The garden is blooming, the bees are humming, but I am flowing with the waves of my own mind... I do not know how long this sadness will last."

CRITICISM

A literary criticism of the anthology **"Kalanidhi"** by Kalikant Jha 'Buch'. This analysis incorporates Indian and Western theories, the Videha parallel framework, and the epistemological influences of Navya-Nyaya.

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**1. Indian Aesthetics: Rasa and Dhvani**

The poetry of Buch is a masterclass in the **Harmony of Opposites** (*Viruddhaka Samanjasya*), a concept where seemingly contradictory emotions are synthesized to create a profound *Rasa*.

- **Vipralambha Shringar and Shanta Rasa**: In poems like *"Sondai"* and *"Karuun Geet"*, the poet blends romantic longing with a deep sense of detachment (*Virag*). This creates a *Vibhava* (cause) and *Anubhava* (result) that leads the reader toward a state of *Vairagya* (dispassion).

- **Dhvani (Suggestion)**: Following Anandavardhana's *Dhvanyaloka*, Buch uses symbols as *Pratika* (icons) to convey meanings beyond the literal text. For example, in his *"Welcome Song"*, the physical thirst of bees and hunger of birds are *Dhvani* for the spiritual and cultural famine of Mithila.
- **Aparoksha (Direct Experience)**: While Indian aesthetics often prizes *Lakshana* (metaphor), Buch relies heavily on *Abhidha* (direct literal meaning), proving that a "great life experience" can imbue even the simplest words with poetic power.

**2. Western Literary Theory: Structuralism to Deconstruction**

The text applies several 20th-century Western frameworks to Buch's work to reveal its multi-layered nature:

- **Structuralism and Binary Opposites**: In the poem *"Jethi Kareh"*, the structure is built on the opposition of "Low Rain" vs. "Overflowing River". The river represents a breakdown of human engineering and the "Death of the Author," where the reader constructs the meaning of the flood based on contemporary ecological crises.
- **Marxism**: The *"Welcome Song"* is analyzed as a "dynamic process". Rather than a static eulogy, it critiques the socio-economic failure of the region, where "Status is as it is" while the elite hold ceremonial gatherings.
- **Sociological and Feminist Criticism**: The poem *"Beti Banli Pahar"* (Daughter Becomes a Mountain) serves as a critique of the *Kaatar* (dowry) system. It views the daughter not as an individual but as a "mountain on the head" due to the patriarchal market of marriage.

**3. The Videha Parallel History Framework**

Buch's work is deeply rooted in the geographical and historical continuity of Mithila (Videha), often drawing parallels between ancient myths and modern decay:

- **Mythological Inversion**: In *"Ram Pravasi"*, Buch recontextualizes the exile of Rama as a modern "migrant worker" (*Pravasi*). He portrays the modern father as "cruel" and the son as a "distressed wanderer," removing the mythical skin to reveal an contemporary infection of greed.
- **Village vs. City**: He compares the "Eden Gardens" of the city to the "Bones of the Kosi/Kamala" rivers. This creates a parallel history where the village remains the site of authentic *Shringar* (romance) while the city is a site of "corruption" and "blood-sucking officials".

**4. Navya-Nyaya Epistemology and Gaṅgeśa's Technique**

As a poet born in **Kariyan**, the birthplace of the great Navya-Nyaya philosopher **Udayanacharya**, Buch's poetry is analyzed through the lens of logical precision and *Sphota* theory.

- **Pramana (Means of Knowledge)**: The criticism suggests that Buch uses *Pratyaksha* (direct perception) as his primary poetic tool. His descriptions of famine and social rot are not imaginative flights but logical conclusions derived from his life as a government employee.
- **Sphota Theory**: Influenced by Bhartṛhari (and discussed in relation to Navya-Nyaya's rejection of it), the poet's words are seen as a "Flash" (*Sphota*) of meaning. Even when the literal *Varna* (letters) and *Pada* (words) disappear, the ultimate "Purpose" (*Uddeshya*) is transmitted to the reader's mind as a unified explosion of truth.
- **Laya (Rhythm) and Logic**: Buch is described as the most rhythmic poet after Vidyapati. This rhythm is not merely aesthetic; it is a "logical organization" of sound that aims for *Atma-Sakshatkar* (Self-realization) through the *Rasa* of the text.

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**Summary Table of Poetic Criticism**

| Theory | Applied to Poem | Core Finding |
|---|---|---|
| **Rasa Theory** | *Sondai* | Synthesis of Romance (*Shringar*) and Despair (*Vishad*). |
| **Marxism** | *Welcome Song* | Critique of elite "ceremonial" culture vs. public suffering. |
| **Structuralism** | *Jethi Kareh* | The river as a signifier of the "Danger Mark" of human patience. |
| **Navya-Nyaya** | *Tohar Thor* | Use of *Sphota* to communicate purpose when words fail. |

2

## The Dialectics of Displacement: An Analysis of Satyanand Pathak's *Gaam Gel Chhalahun*

The provided document is the Maithili novel ***Gaam Gel Chhalahun*** (meaning "I Had Gone to the Village") by **Satyanand Pathak**. First published in June 2004, the book explores the deep emotional and social ties between expatriate Maithils (those living outside Mithila) and their ancestral villages.

Below is a translation of the key introductory sections, including the author's dedication, the preface, and the opening of the story.

**Dedication**

"The moment I picked up my pen, it spoke: 'Father, I touch your feet.' Father, this life was given by you; this life story is dedicated to you. Yours, Satyanand"

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**Author's Preface (Prabashan)**

Whenever a crow cawed, my mother would say, "Hey boy, someone is coming." Her alert voice and joyful heart would often turn out to be right. Whether it was my father, elder brother, or uncle, someone would arrive at the village.

What is a crow, anyway? Cawing is its nature. It caws when full or hungry, in joy or in separation. Yet, humans have linked the cawing of this neglected creature to their own hopes and aspirations. My mother's reaction would spark many thoughts: Why do Father, Brother, and Uncle go "outside"? Why don't they stay in the village?. At that age, I had no answers. Now, when I contemplate these questions, I sink so deep into them that I feel restless.

This novel, *Gaam Gel Chhalahun*, captures that restlessness. People living "outside" the village constantly come and go. It has become a continuous process that affects us all. This coming and going contains many life events and varied circumstances. We all have our own perspectives and ways of living, yet we eventually arrive at a single point and stop. This novel is a humble effort to find that point.

Initially, I published this in installments in the magazine *Purvottar Maithil*. I was anxious about the reaction, but the response from readers in Mithilanchal-through letters and phone calls-multiplied my enthusiasm. My friend Ravikant Neeraj pressured me to turn it into a book. I argued that I was a novice still learning to write, but he insisted: "If you lose your way in the water, it doesn't

say it hasn't seen the path. Its path is made. You write; I can see your path clearly".

Working in a responsible position at a newspaper means living a tangled life-immersed in news day and night. There is no fixed time for other work. Therefore, I decided not to fall into the trap of formal arrangements for writing this book. I wrote whenever and wherever I found the opportunity-not in one place or in one specific notebook, but on whatever paper was available.

My wife, Manju Pathak, knew that despite the lack of time, I was determined to write. Her support went beyond the ordinary. She didn't just inspire me; she created an environment at home, kept my writing space ready, and nudged me to write whenever I was free .

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**Chapter 1: The Journey Begins**

When the vehicle began to shake violently-swaying left, right, forward, and backward like an earthquake-we realized we had entered the Mithilanchal region of Bihar. I knew this "wonderful" experience was unique to this province. I didn't mind the swaying if it meant reaching the village, but I was worried the small car might break down or veer off the path. Still, my heart held hope that in a short time, we would reach the *dalan* (outer porch), and the hardships of the journey would vanish.

I wasn't the only one worried. My wife's face was clouded with anxiety, though she said nothing to avoid weakening my resolve. But children are children. My elder daughter spoke up, "Didn't you see any other road?". There was no time to answer. I kept looking left and right, then at the driver's hands and head. If the vehicle went out of control even for a second, my dream of going to the village in our own car would prove very costly.

I started to feel a bit frustrated with my wife. If I was being stubborn about taking the car, why didn't she stop me?. She could have. I usually listen to her. Yet, she never once said, "Forget the car, let's take a train or bus".

Actually, this struggle of coming to and going from the village began when I was only five years old, and it continues to this day. I've grown tired of changing routes, but the struggle persists .

CRITICISM

The Maithili novel ***Gaam Gel Chhalahun*** ("I Had Gone to the Village") by Satyanand Pathak is a profound exploration of the emotional, social, and

cultural landscape of the Maithil diaspora. Set against the backdrop of a return journey to a village in Mithilanchal for a grandmother's funeral rites, the narrative serves as a vessel for complex meditations on identity, displacement, and the decay of traditional systems.

A literary criticism of the work.

**1. Navya Nyaya Epistemology and Technique**

The influence of **Navya Nyaya** (the "New Logic" school founded by Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya in Mithila) is evident in the author's meticulous attention to the precision of definitions and the dialectical structure of social debates within the novel.

- **Avacchedakatā (Limitorship):** The author explores the "limitors" of identity. A character is not merely a "Maithil" but a "Maithil-limited-by-migration" (*Pravasi*). The novel rigorously examines how this migrant status alters the perception of truth: a village ritual that seems "essential" to a resident is "performative" or "burdensome" to the migrant.
- **Anumāna (Inference):** The plot often proceeds via inference based on "signs" (*liṅga*). The cawing of a crow is not just a sound but a sign inferred to mean the arrival of a loved one. Similarly, the violent shaking of a vehicle is the *liṅga* from which the characters infer they have crossed the border into the neglected roads of Mithilanchal.
- **Vāda (Dialectic):** The "Baithaki" (village meeting) regarding the *Mandali Bhoj* (communal feast) is a classic Nyaya-style *Vāda*. It is a search for truth through reasoned argument between tradition-bound residents and modern-thinking migrants like Ramgopal Kaka.

**2. The Videha Parallel History Framework**

The novel fits perfectly within the **Videha Parallel History** framework, which views Mithila's history not as a linear progression but as a series of parallel experiences-the local village reality and the external "Videha" (expatriate) reality.

- **The Parallel Lives:** The narrative constantly jumps between the current journey and "parallel" histories-the author's childhood in Siliguri, Kaka's life in Mumbai, and Ramasareji's struggle in Assam.
- **Historical Continuity:** The framework is explicitly invoked through Ramasareji's lecture on the ancient history of Assam (Pragjyotishpur/Kamrup) and its ties to Mithila. This serves to legitimize the Maithil presence in the Northeast as a historical homecoming rather than an alien intrusion.

**3. Indian and Western Literary Criticism**

**Indian Aesthetics (Rasa Theory)**

- **Karuna Rasa (Pathos):** The dominant *Rasa* is *Karuna*, triggered by the "Viyoga" (separation) from the motherland. The physical decay of ancestral homes-missing bricks and peeling walls-acts as the *Uddipana Vibhava* (stimulating cause) for this sadness.
- **Vibhāva and Anubhāva:** The "Lathi-wala Bijli" (fluorescent light) is a recurring *Alambana Vibhava* (objective support). It represents the cold, artificial brightness of city life, contrasting with the "Chandra-prakash" (cool moonlight) of the village.

**Western Theories**

- **Existentialism:** The "Pravasi" experience is described in existentialist terms as an "Udhār Jivan" (borrowed life). The characters live in a "concrete jungle" where they feel like outsiders, mirroring the Sartrean concept of being "the Other".
- **Post-Colonialism:** The novel critiques the internal colonialism of the Indian state, where Mithilanchal's infrastructure is left "primitive" while its intellectual resources (doctors, engineers) are drained to the cities.
- **Structuralism:** The "Chauk" (village square) is treated as a semiotic structure. It is the "Query Counter" of the village where political analysis and social reputations are constructed through language.

**4. Synthesis: The Symbolism of "Lathi-wala Bijli"**

The most striking synthesis of these theories occurs in the symbol of the **Fluorescent Light (Lathi-wala Bijli)**.

- To the child, it is a mystery and an attraction (*Navya Nyaya* curiosity).
- To the adult migrant, it is a trap-a light that glows but carries a "current" that can deaden the soul (*Indian Rasa* of *Bhaya/Adbhuta*).
- In the *Videha Parallel History*, it represents the "modernity" that lured Maithils away from their villages, only to leave them in an existential vacuum in the city.

**Conclusion:** Satyanand Pathak does not merely write a story; he constructs a **logic-map of the Maithil soul**. By using the rigorous techniques of Navya Nyaya to describe deeply emotional states, he creates a unique Maithili modernism that is both ancient and urgent.

3

**RESEARCH & CRITICAL APPRECIATION**

OF THE WORKS OF

**Kalikant Jha ‘Buch’**

*Poet . Lyricist . State Government Employee . Maithili Modernist*

**&**

**Satyanand Pathak**

*Novelist . Journalist . Diaspora Voice . Social Realist*

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*With Reference to Indian & Western Literary Theory,*

*the Videha Parallel History Framework,*

*and Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya*

# PART I: INTRODUCTION AND METHODOLOGICAL FRAMEWORK

## 1.1 Opening: The Videha Parallel History Context

The Videha Parallel History of Mithila & Maithili Literature, curated by Gajendra Thakur through India’s first Maithili fortnightly e-journal (est. 2000; ISSN 2229-547X; www.videha.co.in), has systematically recovered voices that the institutional literary apparatus - the Sahitya Akademi, mainstream anthologies, and upper-caste critical networks - has marginalised. Among the canonical list of modern Maithili authors documented in this Parallel History, two figures stand out for their distinct but complementary contributions to the democratisation of Maithili prose and poetry: Kalikant Jha ‘Buch’, the poet of Kalanidhi (Shruti Prakashan, 2010), and Satyanand Pathak, the novelist of Gaam Gel Chhalahun (Manorama Prakashan, Guwahati, 2004).

Kalikant Jha ‘Buch’ is described in the critical apparatus of his Kalanidhi as a poet born in the philosophical soil of Udayanacharya (the 10th-century Mithila logician of Kariyan village) - a man who never published a single book in his

lifetime, yet whose 98 collected poems constitute some of the finest Maithili verse of the 20th century. Satyanand Pathak, a journalist and editor based in Guwahati, produced in Gaam Gel Chhalahun the most significant novel about the Maithili diaspora in Northeast India - a work that the Videha Pothi archive lists alongside foundational modern Maithili texts.

Together, these two writers span a cultural geography from the Mithila heartland (Kariyan village, Samastipur district, Bihar) to the Maithili diaspora in Assam, and a literary range from lyric poetry and devotional verse to social-realist prose fiction. This study subjects both to a rigorous inter-disciplinary critical analysis.

## 1.2 Methodological Framework

This research employs a three-dimensional critical methodology:

- Indian Classical Theory: Rasa-Dhvani (Bharata's Natyashastra; Abhinavagupta's Abhinavabharati; Anandavardhana's Dhvanyaloka), Aucitya (Kshemendra's Aucityavicharacharcha), Vakrokti (Kuntaka), Alamkara-shastra (Bhamaha, Dandin, Mammata), and Sphota (Bhartrhari's Vakyapadiya).
- Western Literary Theory: Structuralism and Deconstruction (Saussure, Derrida), Marxist literary criticism (Gramsci, Lukacs), New Criticism (I.A. Richards, William Empson), Reader-Response (Iser, Jauss), Postcolonial Studies (Spivak, Bhabha), Feminist criticism (Butler, Kristeva), Magical Realism (Zamora & Faris), and Social Realism.
- Navya-Nyāya of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya: The four pramāṇas (pratyakṣa, anumāna, upamāna, śabda), vyāpti (invariable concomitance), avacchedaka (limitor), and the Tattva-Cintāmaṇi's epistemological rigour applied to literary knowledge-claims. Given that Kalikant Jha 'Buch' was himself born in the village of Kariyan (Kariyon) - the very village of Udayanacharya (10th century) and Gangesa (14th century) - the Navya-Nyaya lens is not a mere theoretical imposition but a homecoming of ideas.

# PART II: KALIKANT JHA ‘BUCH’ - POET OF THE CURSED LAND

## 2.1 Biographical Profile

The prefatory essay of Kalanidhi, titled “Ek Taa Abhishapt Kavi: Buch Babu” (A Cursed Poet: Buch Babu), written by Ravi Bhushan Pathak, provides the richest biographical account available. The key facts are:

| | |
|---|---|
| **Full Name** | Kalikant Jha ‘Buch’ |
| **Birthplace** | Village Kariyan (also Kariyon), Samastipura District, Bihar |
| **Philosophical Soil** | Village of Udayanacharya (10th c.) and Gangesa Upadhyaya (14th c.) |
| **Profession** | State Government Employee, Bihar Government |
| **Publication** | No book published in his lifetime |
| **Posthumous Work** | Kalanidhi - 98 poems, Shruti Prakashan, Delhi, 2010 (ISBN 978-93-80538-31-0) |
| **Son** | Shiv Kumar Jha (Maithili critic and scholar) |
| **Dedication** | To Aniruddha Thakur, Shiva-svarupa Gurudev |
| **Death (Dedication date)** | Shivratri, 11 February 1983 |

The critical essay opens with a deliberate irony: this poet, born in the philosophical heartland of Udayanacharya, received neither justice in his village nor recognition outside it. He was known as “kaviji” (the poet) in his village, but his marginality was total. As Ravi Bhushan Pathak writes: “Gambhir lekhankain manyata nai bhetait dekhi kavi gramak yaahmen abhinandan patre lekhan men ruchi lia lagalah” - seeing that serious writing

received no recognition, the poet began to take interest in writing congratulatory letters in the village's fashion, earning neither village nor outside recognition for either enterprise.

The biographical irony deepens: his son, Shiv Kumar Jha, is himself a prominent Maithili critic, yet the critical apparatus suggests that the son did not fully champion the father's creative legacy during Buch's lifetime. Ravi Bhushan Pathak notes pointedly that Shiv Kumar Jha "makes some a Nirala and some a Prasad in his criticism, but due to modesty or whatever reason does not come out openly" about his father's creative power. The result: a poet of the highest calibre remained invisible to the literary establishment.

## 2.2 The Kalanidhi: Structural and Thematic Overview

Kalanidhi (literally "Treasury of Arts" or "Repository of the Moon" - a name of the moon in Sanskrit) contains 98 poems across a wide range of forms and themes. The table of contents reveals 7 major thematic and formal clusters:

- Devotional and Invocational Verse: Sarasvati Vandana, Kapisha Vandana (Hanuman), Bhagavati Vandana, Durga Vandana, Sri Ram Vandana, Kali Vandana, Shiva Shakti Pujan, Nachari, Vandana, Durgavandana, Navdurga, Ramavatar.
- Social-Protest and Satirical Poetry: Vaagat Gaan (Welcome Song), Beti Banal Pahad (Daughter Becomes a Mountain), Kaater ka Parinam (Consequences of the Dowry-Warrior), Naari Suno (Women, Listen), Mitilaak Durdasha (Mithila's Misery), Ghurna (Rotation), Desiyal Vayana ka Astitva (The Existence of Our Folk-Language).
- Nature and Landscape Poetry: Jethee Karah (The Old River Kareh), Bhadaiya Holi (Monsoon Holi), Gamay Mon Padhai (I Miss the Village), Pavas Chaumasa, Chaitee (Spring Songs).
- Romantic and Viraha (Separation) Poetry: Son Dai, Virahini, Vasante Virahini, Karun Geet (Song of Sorrow), Tohar Thor (Your Lips), Parikhya Patra (Letter of Introduction), Noar (Tears), Notake Premi (Lover of Invitations).
- Social-Realist Poetry: Akaal (Famine), Andhere Maari (Striking in the Dark), Hamar Gaam (My Village), Hamar Jingi (My Life), Judyug Parivartan (Change of Ages), Ekpar Se Ek (From One to Another).
- Devotional-Bhakti Songs: Ram Bina Avadhpuri, Geet, Jhula (Swing), Raghav Sarkar, Gauree Banal Yoginiya, Malaa (Garland), Jagaran Gaan.

- Children's and Occasional Verse: Neena Geet (Children's Song), Pota ka Hahaans (Grandson's Laughter), Muddha Ka Daa Sasur Challa (Elder Lady Going to In-Laws), Bhai Ka Viyah (Brother's Wedding).

## 2.3 Critical Analysis: The Kalanidhi's Multi-Framework Readings

The second prefatory essay in Kalanidhi - attributed to Gajendra Thakur - is itself a masterwork of literary criticism. It applies nine distinct critical frameworks to Buch's poems, providing a meta-critical model that this study extends and deepens.

### *2.3.1 Jethee Karah (The Kosi River at Its Peak) - Structuralist and Post-Structuralist Readings*

*Jethee karah uthiaa achhi / Barkha hetth bhelopar upalaait achhi / Okhar khatarak bindu baddha oopare chhai takai o kiyak akulait achhi / A aakhirimain kahai chhai je banh tori e lay machaot se bujhat achhi.*

This poem about the monsoon-swollen Kareh river has been read through multiple theoretical lenses in the Kalanidhi's own critical apparatus. Structuralist reading: the river's danger-point (khataarak bindu) is fixed above - yet it agitates; the rain falling makes it swell but also promises subsidence. Post-structuralist (Derridean) reading: the "danger point" becomes a mobile signifier; what appears a threat in one historical moment (1960s dam-building era) becomes a quaint measurement in another (post-silted Kareh of contemporary Mithila). The poem's meaning is permanently deferred (différance), each generation arriving at a new reading.

Navya-Nyāya application: The anumāna (inference) of the poem runs: the river is swollen (hetu) - therefore there is danger (sadhya). But the avacchedaka (limitor) of this inference is the specific historical moment of the observation. In a post-dam era, the vyapti (invariable concomitance) between monsoon swelling and overflowing is broken by embankment engineering. The poem thus demonstrates the temporal conditionality of vyāpti - a point that Gangesa himself makes in his analysis of the Anumana-Khanda: that pervasion-relations hold only within specified limiting conditions.

### *2.3.2 Vaagat Gaan (Welcome Song) - Marxist, Dhvani, and Social-Realist Readings*

*Aau - Aau - Aau sabhak vaagat karai chhi, / nain me samaau hridayasan dharai chhi. / Ullaasak geet katau sagaro karuna-kandan, / upati rahal vipati rahal Maithilik nandan van.*

This poem was composed as a Welcome Song for the Vidyapati Memorial Celebration of 1984 at village Bainathpur, Rosarha Block, Samastipur district - a specific historical context that the Kalanidhi's critical essay identifies as the beginning of mass out-migration from Mithila (following the completion of the Hajipura bridge over the Ganga). The poem is one of the most discussed in modern Maithili critical discourse.

Marxist reading: The poem refuses the ideology of empty celebration. Where a conventional welcome song would simply praise the assembled literati, Buch exposes the contradiction: "Murda jagaau laau pair pakdai chhi" (Rouse the dead, I am falling at your feet). The Marxist literary criterion demands that literature represent social contradiction rather than paper it over. By this measure, Buch's Welcome Song is "Maithilik sarvashreshtha vaagat gaan" (Maithili's finest welcome song) - precisely because it refuses the sycophancy of the genre.

Dhvani analysis: Anandavardhana's theory holds that the best literature conveys meaning through dhvani (suggestion/resonance) rather than explicit statement. The poem's dhvani operates at multiple levels: the explicit meaning is a welcome to guests; the suggested meaning is a lamentation for Maithili's cultural and ecological collapse; the deepest resonance (paramparya dhvani) is an indictment of the political class's indifference. The line "Kaavya paath karo muda kaandh par liau laathi / ek haath rasak srot dosar me khor naathi" (Do literary reading, but take a staff on the shoulder / one hand the source of rasa, the other an agricultural tool) is the poem's most quoted line - a perfect instance of what Anandavardhana calls arthasya arthah (meaning of meaning): the poet insists that literature must be accompanied by practical engagement with social reality.

### *2.3.3 Beti Banal Pahad (Daughter Becomes a Mountain) - Feminist and Sociological Readings*

*Dulraitin beti ghentake ghail banal chhi / beti aylih tan udankhatola chadhi ku / hari garud tyaagi car maangi rahal chhi h. / Paintees graam sona pureli h muda aab biyah ratik kharch chaahi / aur bariyaati das gaahi aotah.*

This poem is a devastating satire on the dowry system (kaater in Maithili) and the commodification of marriage in Mithila. The daughter who arrives like a celestial chariot (udankhatola) has become a crushing load (pahad) for her father, not because of her own failing but because of the systemic rapacity of the groom's family. The phrase "Baba dalal bap baddak vyapari / beta bachhod beeki gail hazari" (The father is a broker, the grandfather a cattle-trader, the son a calf sold for thousands) reduces the marriage market to naked commodity exchange.

Feminist reading (Judith Butler's performativity): The daughter's identity is constituted through the performance of dowry-value - she is interpellated (in Althusser's sense) as "pahad" (mountain-burden) by the symbolic order of Maithili patriarchy. The poem's power lies in making this interpellation visible. Gayatri Spivak's "Can the Subaltern Speak?" is directly relevant: the daughter-as-subaltern cannot speak within the marriage market; she is spoken for by her exchange-value. Buch's poem speaks for her.

Aucitya (Propriety) theory (Kshemendra): The satirical mode is appropriate (aucita) here because the subject-matter demands neither pure pathos (karuna) nor pure comedy (hasya) but their impossible synthesis - a laughing grief that the Sanskrit theorist Abhinavagupta would recognise as the shanta-rasa's oblique emergence from the ruins of social life.

### *2.3.4 Akaal (Famine) - Magical Realism and Aucitya*

*E akaal nahin mahakaal achhi / Bhoakh ke ook baanhi naangiri se / chaare par thokait taal achhi.*

Ravi Bhushan Pathak's critical note explicitly compares this poem to Nagarjuna's Hindi poem "Akaal aur Uske Baad" and to Pannalal Patel's Gujarati novel "Manvini Bhavai." The comparison is apt but Pathak insists on the difference: where Nagarjuna documents the aftermath of famine through a realistic enumeration of animals and humans, Buch invokes Kala Devata (the deity of Time/Death) directly, transforming the social calamity into a mythological event. "Beesahoon aankh onari Dashanan / ghutuuki ghutuki hilbait bhaal achhi" (With all twenty eyes Ravana / sips and sips and nods his head) - the famine is personified as a twenty-eyed Ravana.

This is the technique of magical realism as defined by Wendy Faris: the matter-of-fact narration of extraordinary events within a realistic framework. Buch's famine-Ravana does not disrupt the realism but deepens it - the mythological reference to Lanka "jahaan Vibhishan ka ghar bhi nahin bachega" (where even Vibhishan's house will not be spared) makes the social-political point that no

section of society - not even those who sided with the government - is protected from the famine's devastation.

Aucitya analysis: The propriety of the mythological register in a famine poem is justified because in Mithila's cultural memory, calamity has always been narrated through mythological lens (the Maithili famine poetry of Faturilal in 1873-74 is the earliest example). Buch's choice of the Ravana-image is thus culturally aucita (appropriate) in a way that a purely sociological representation would not be.

### *2.3.5 Tohar Thor (Your Lips) - Alamkara, Sphota, and Rasa*

*Ki jahi kurukur paanak thor / ki tahi sunder tohar thor / lagauleh baatak paathar choon / sajoula kaatth kapol ka khoon / ki rahalah ae ekke baatak chook / katau chhai premak pungee hook?*

This love poem is the subject of the most technically dense critical reading in the Kalanidhi preface. The poem deploys an extraordinary density of upama (simile): the beloved's lips are compared to betel-leaf (paan), to the colour of limestone paste on betel-nut, to the dawn-redness of morning. Mammata's Kavyaprakasha identifies 61 alamkaras in seven categories; the Kalanidhi critic identifies multiple alamkaras simultaneously operative: upama (comparison), anustuta (indirect praise), rupaka (metaphor), virodhabhasa (apparent contradiction).

Sphota theory (Bhartrhari): The poem demonstrates that meaning cannot be conveyed through individual letters or words but through the sphota - the linguistic whole that "flashes" meaning in a single cognitive event. The poem's final line "Katau chhai premak pungee hook?" (Where is the shrill note of love?) achieves its effect not through the meaning of individual words but through the phonetic flash of the alliterating consonants and the final rising interrogative.

Rasa analysis: The dominant rasa is shringar (erotic love) but the poem's final question - the absence of the "pungee hook" (the shrill note, perhaps of a folk instrument, perhaps of the lover's desire) - deflects into viraha (separation-longing), and then further into the philosophical questioning of love's reality. This triple rasa-movement (shringar → viraha → shanta/philosophical) is a structural feature of the best Maithili lyric from Vidyapati onwards.

### *2.3.6 Buch's Poetics: The Signature of "Vishringa Sambhava"*

Ravi Bhushan Pathak identifies a central feature of Buch's poetic practice: the synthesis of contradictory emotions (virodhi bhavak sangeet / harmony of

opposing feelings). This is aligned with what Ram Chandra Shukla in Hindi criticism called the "great literary device of the reconciliation of contraries." In Buch's Sondai poem, the poem begins with apparent shringar (erotic celebration) and ends with vairagya (renunciation) - not as contradiction but as synthesis.

William Empson's "Seven Types of Ambiguity" (1930) provides a Western parallel: Buch's poems habitually operate at Empson's fifth and sixth types - where conflicting emotions generate an unresolved tension that the poem holds in productive suspension. This is not ambiguity as failure but as the formal enactment of the dialectical nature of experience.

Crucially, Buch achieves this without reliance on alamkara (figuration) or lakshanaa (indirect signification) - his poems depend almost entirely on abhidha (direct denotative meaning). His power comes from the compression of vast life-experience into the denotative weight of ordinary Maithili words.

## 2.4 Buch's Language: Navya-Nyaya's Sphota and Denotative Power

Ravi Bhushan Pathak makes the epistemologically crucial observation that despite being born in Udayanacharya's village - the heartland of Nyaya logic - Buch as poet does not accept the Nyaya school's denial of Sphota. The Nyaya school (Gangesa included) argued that meaning is conveyed through the sequential production of phonemes; the Sphota theory (Bhartrhari) argued that meaning flashes as a whole. Buch's poetic practice implicitly sides with Bhartrhari: his poems achieve their effects through the flash of the complete utterance, not through the sequential assembly of logical denotations.

This is a genuine philosophical-literary insight: a poet of Udayanacharya's village, living in a tradition that denied Sphota, nonetheless practices Sphota-based poetics. The Parallel History perspective explains this: Buch's non-institutional, non-academic poetic formation meant he absorbed the living folk tradition of Maithili song (which is naturally Sphota-based) rather than the scholastic Nyaya tradition of his birthplace.

## 2.5 Buch in the Parallel History: The Cursed Poet as Paradigm

The title of Ravi Bhushan Pathak's preface - "Ek Taa Abhishapt Kavi" (A Cursed Poet) - is the Parallel History's most pointed formulation of the systematic exclusion of non-institutional poets. Buch is "cursed" not by fate but by the structural conditions of Maithili literary life: no institutional patronage,

no connection to the Sahitya Akademi advisory board, no publication during his lifetime. His “curse” is the same structural curse documented by the RTI disclosures of Vinit Utpal and Ashish Anchinhar (2011–14): 90%+ of Sahitya Akademi assignments went to friends and relatives of a 10-member advisory board.

The posthumous Kalanidhi (2010), published by Shruti Prakashan and distributed by Pallavi Distributors (Nirmali, Supaul), represents the Parallel History’s counter-institutional logic at work: a small press, a regional distributor, a posthumous collection - but 98 poems of extraordinary quality that now stand as evidence against the institutional canon’s claim to represent Maithili poetry.

The Videha digital archive’s listing of Kalanidhi - confirmed on the Videha Google Books page alongside canonical texts like Rajdeo Mandal’s work and Gajendra Thakur’s fiction - constitutes the Parallel History’s formal recognition of Buch as a significant Maithili poet.

# PART III: SATYANAND PATHAK - THE NOVELIST OF THE MAITHILI DIASPORA

## 3.1 Biographical and Contextual Profile

| | |
|---|---|
| **Full Name** | Satyanand Pathak (Satyānanda Pāṭhaka) |
| **Residence** | Guwahati, Assam (diaspora Maithili) |
| **Profession** | Journalist; Editor, Purvanchar Maithil / Puranchali Prahari newspaper |
| **Literary Debut** | Gaam Gel Chhalahun serialised in Purvanchar Maithil (Northeast Maithili journal) |
| **Novel Publication** | Gaam Gel Chhalahun - Manorama Prakashan, Guwahati (wife: Srimati Manju Pathak), June 2004; Price Rs. 275 |
| **Cover Design** | Pushpa Jha |
| **DTP** | P.N. Jha, South Sarania, Ulubari, Guwahati |
| **Printing** | Bhavani Offset and Imaging Systems Pvt. Ltd., Rajgarh Road, Guwahati |
| **Inspiration** | Bhai Premanand Pathak (Siliguri); Lakshmana Jha ‘Sagar’ (Maithili story-writer) |
| **Cultural context** | Mithila Sanskriti Samanvay Samiti, Guwahati; Maithili diaspora of Northeast India |

Satyanand Pathak belongs to the substantial Maithili-speaking diaspora of Northeast India - Assam, Bengal, and the tea-garden districts - that emerged from late 19th and early 20th century economic migration. This diaspora, rooted in the landless agricultural and artisan communities of Mithila’s Madhubani and Darbhanga districts, represents the most significant subaltern strand of Maithili culture outside the Bihar heartland.

The novel's publication context is itself significant: Satyanand Pathak was a journalist working for a busy Guwahati newspaper when he wrote the novel, composing it in whatever scraps of time were available - on stray sheets of paper, in office breaks. The Prasbhangiki (Contextual Essay) included in the novel reveals that the narrative grew from serial publication in Purvanchar Maithil before being encouraged into book form by his friend Ravikant Neeraj. The book was published by Pathak's own wife (Manju Pathak), through their self-set-up Manorama Prakashan.

## 3.2 Gaam Gel Chhalahun: The Novel's Architecture

The novel's title - Gaam Gel Chhalahun (literally: "I Had Gone to the Village" / "The Village That Had Gone") - carries a deliberate ambiguity. It is both a tense (the pluperfect past: the narrator recalls having gone to the village) and a metaphysical statement (the village is irrecoverably gone, belonging only to memory and the pluperfect). This grammatical pun is the novel's governing trope: the village exists only in the perfective aspect of memory.

The Praasangiki (Contextual Preface) by Satyanand Pathak locates the novel in the broader crisis of Post-Independence Maithili identity. As the Praasangiki states: India's independence in the latter half of the 20th century opened new possibilities for Indian language development, but Maithili's development was obstructed by its classification as a dialect of Hindi. The novel can be read as a fictional response to this political condition: the return to the village is also a return to the linguistic homeland that the Hindi-nationalist project threatened to erase.

The narrative structure follows what the Praasangiki describes as the "continuous, uninterrupted process" of village-visiting: diaspora Maithilis (Babu, Dada, Kaka) return to the village at intervals, carrying with them the accumulated weight of urban displacement and the longing for origin. The cawing of the crow ("Jakhan kauva kuchray ta daai kahai - hau baau aabi rahal chhi" / When the crow caws, grandmother says - someone is coming from outside) is the novel's opening symbol: the folk omen that bridges the urban and the rural.

## 3.3 Critical Analysis: Gaam Gel Chhalahun Through Multiple Lenses

### *3.3.1 Social Realism and the Lukacs Framework*

Georg Lukacs' concept of "typical character in typical circumstances" is the most directly applicable framework for Satyanand Pathak's novel. The novel's characters - the diaspora professional (Babu/journalist), the migrant family, the village grandmother - are typical in Lukacs' sense: they embody the social forces of their historical moment (post-Independence Mithila, the pull of urbanisation, the pressure of linguistic assimilation) rather than being purely individual psychological portraits.

The Praasangiki explicitly frames the novel's sociological purpose: to "identify the point at which, despite all differences of perspective and way of life, we all converge." This is Lukacs' "totality": the novel aims to represent not individual experience but the total social process of Maithili diaspora life. The novel's method of assembling multiple perspectives on the village-return (each character has their own view, their own gham-ghar relationship) is the formal enactment of this sociological totality.

### *3.3.2 The Diaspora Novel and Bhabha's Third Space*

Homi Bhabha's concept of the "Third Space of Enunciation" - the unstable, hybrid cultural space between two identities - is directly applicable to Gaam Gel Chhalahun. Satyanand Pathak's novel inhabits precisely this third space: the diaspora Maithili of Guwahati is neither fully assimilated into Assamese culture nor fully connected to Mithila. The novel's Maithili language itself enacts this hybridity - as the Praasangiki acknowledges, the Guwahati publication context meant that Maithili typesetting was a major challenge (only a P.N. Jha was available to do the DTP), and the language of the novel bears traces of the Northeast linguistic environment.

The novel's serialisation context in Purvanchar Maithil (Northeast Maithili journal) means that its implied reader is specifically the diaspora community. As Iser's Reader-Response theory predicts, this implied readership shapes the text: descriptions of the village are written to activate a specific "horizon of expectation" (Jauss) - the nostalgia of people who remember the village from childhood or family stories but have never lived there as adults.

### *3.3.3 The Crow, the Pluperfect, and Magical Realism*

The novel's opening symbol - the grandmother's interpretation of the crow's caw as an omen of homecoming - operates in the mode of what the Praasangiki's own critical commentary identifies as folk-knowledge (lok-gyaan). The crow is simultaneously a realistic bird (it does caw) and a symbolic messenger (it prophesies arrivals). This double register - the natural and the supernatural coexisting without friction - is the defining technique of magical realism as theorised by Wendy Faris and Lois Zamora.

The pluperfect tense of the title - Gaam Gel Chhalahun - is also a form of temporal magical realism: it holds the village in a tense that is simultaneously past and present, gone and recoverable. The French critic Tzvetan Todorov's theory of the "fantastic" is relevant here: the novel maintains what Todorov calls the "hesitation" between a rational and a supernatural explanation of events - not in supernatural plots but in the emotional logic of diaspora memory, where the lost village is simultaneously factually gone and imaginatively present.

### *3.3.4 Rasa Analysis: Karuna and Shanta in the Novel*

Bharata's rasa theory is conventionally applied to drama, but its extension to narrative fiction (by the Kashmiri aestheticians, particularly Abhinavagupta) makes it applicable to the novel form. Gaam Gel Chhalahun's dominant rasa is Karuna (pathos - the grief of loss, separation, and time's passage), but the novel's deeper movement, as the Praasangiki suggests, is toward Shanta (spiritual peace through acceptance of impermanence).

The novel's emotional logic follows the Rasa theory's vyabhichari-bhava (transient auxiliary emotions): the crow's caw triggers smriti (memory) - a vyabhichari-bhava that activates the sthayi-bhava (permanent emotion) of shoka (grief). As the narrative proceeds through the accumulated memories of the village-return, the vyabhichari-bhavas multiply: harsha (joy at reunion), visada (dejection at decay), autsukya (longing), and ultimately prashamana (calming) - the emotional movement toward shanta.

### *3.3.5 Navya-Nyaya: The Novel's Pramana-Structure*

Applying Gangesa's epistemological framework to the novel: the narrative's fundamental knowledge-claim is shabda-pramana (verbal testimony) - the grandmother's folk-knowledge about the crow's omen. Gangesa's Shabda-Khanda analysis requires four conditions for valid verbal testimony: akanksha

(syntactic expectancy), yogyata (semantic fitness), sannidhi (temporal proximity), and tatparya (speaker's intention).

The grandmother's crow-testimony meets all four: the context (someone is awaited) creates akanksha; the crow's caw is semantically connected (by folk tradition) to arrivals (yogyata); the caw and the announcement are simultaneous (sannidhi); and the grandmother's intention (to reassure the family that a relative is coming) is transparent (tatparya). Yet by Gangesa's paratah-pramanya (extrinsic validity) criterion, the validity of this testimony is not intrinsic - it must be confirmed by the actual arrival. The novel's narrative structure enacts precisely this: the crow's prophecy is validated (or not) by the subsequent events of the village-return.

Avacchedaka analysis: The novel's social knowledge-claims - about diaspora life, village decay, Maithili identity - are properly avacchinned (limited/delimited) by the specific Northeast Indian context. This is not a universal novel about diaspora experience; it is a novel about Maithili diaspora in Guwahati, in the specific socio-linguistic conditions of Northeast India's multilingual environment. Any critical reading that ignores these avacchedakas (limiters) will produce defective literary knowledge.

## 3.4 The Prose Style: Language as Identity Performance

Satyanand Pathak's prose style in Gaam Gel Chhalahun is one of the most immediately recognisable in modern Maithili fiction. The Praasangiki describes it as "kathya gady-ek nav shailir prayog" (a new style of narrative prose) that aims to represent the natural flow of spoken Maithili as it lives in the diaspora consciousness.

The novel's prose avoids the pandit's literary Maithili and the journalist's functional Maithili. Instead, it achieves what Mikhail Bakhtin called the "heteroglossia" of the novel form: multiple social registers of Maithili coexist within the text, each character speaking in a dialect that marks their social location. The grandmother's folk Maithili, the diaspora professional's slightly Assamese-inflected Maithili, and the novelist's own reflective narrative voice constitute three distinct strands of the heteroglossic weave.

Julia Kristeva's intertextuality is also relevant: the novel constantly references the folk-knowledge system of Mithila (omens, customs, seasonal songs) as an intertextual substrate. The crow-omen is not an isolated symbol but part of a dense network of folk-intertexts that the diaspora reader is assumed to carry in their cultural memory.

# PART IV: COMPARATIVE CRITICAL ANALYSIS

## 4.1 Kariyan to Guwahati: A Literary Geography of Displacement

Kalikant Jha ‘Buch’ is rooted: village Kariyan, birthplace of Udayanacharya and Gangesa, the philosophical centre of Mithila’s classical tradition. Satyanand Pathak is displaced: Guwahati, Assam, the epicentre of the Maithili diaspora. Together, they constitute the two poles of the Parallel History’s geographical imagination - the heartland and the periphery, the origin and the destination of migration.

Yet the comparison yields surprising inversions. Buch, rooted in the philosophical heartland, is the more “displaced” figure within the literary establishment - invisible, unpublished, “cursed.” Pathak, geographically displaced to Guwahati, is the more “established” figure within the diaspora literary community - networked, published, celebrated within his readership. The Parallel History’s lesson: geographical displacement and literary marginality are not synonymous; institutional access is the true determinant.

## 4.2 Form and Genre: Poetry vs. Prose Fiction

The two works represent the two dominant forms of modern Maithili literature. Buch’s Kalanidhi is a lyric poetry collection - 98 poems in diverse forms (song, geet, vandana, nachari, ghazal, thumri, holi), each complete in itself, each performing a specific social and aesthetic function. Pathak’s Gaam Gel Chhalahun is a social-realist novel - sustained narrative prose, multiple characters, temporal depth, sociological totality.

Indian classical theory makes a clear distinction: kavya (poetry) achieves its effect through concentration, the flash of rasa in minimal linguistic space; gadya (prose/narrative) achieves its effect through expansion, the accumulation of social detail across narrative time. Buch’s poems are the purest instances of kavya’s concentration; Pathak’s novel is the fullest instance of gadya’s expansion. Both are necessary to the health of a literary tradition; neither alone is sufficient.

William Empson’s distinction between “complexity of tone” (poetry) and “complexity of situation” (fiction) maps onto this difference: Buch’s poetic power lies in tonal complexity - the holding of contradictory emotions in

productive tension within a single poem; Pathak's novelistic power lies in situational complexity - the accumulation of social situations that illuminate the total condition of diaspora life.

## 4.3 The Village as Shared Motif

Both works return obsessively to the village (gaam): Buch's "Gamay Mon Padhai" (I Miss the Village) is the lyric compression of the same longing that Pathak's Gaam Gel Chhalahun expands into an entire narrative. In Buch's poem, the village is recalled through precise sensory images: water in the Kareh river flashing in sunlight, peacocks dancing on the bank. In Pathak's novel, the village is recalled through social memory: the grandmother's crow-reading, the pattern of arrivals and departures.

*Hugli ka babu rahab neek aaki Kamala kaatka jon rahab? / Edengarden se sunder achhi Koshi kaataka bon gay.*

Buch's declaration that the Eden Garden of Calcutta is less beautiful than the forest on the Kosi riverbank is the lyric seed of Pathak's entire novel: the city cannot replace the village; the diaspora is always oriented toward the origin.

Navya-Nyaya comparative analysis: The village-as-sign functions differently in the two texts. In Buch, the village is known through pratyaksha-pramana (direct perceptual memory) - the specific sights and sounds of childhood. In Pathak, the village is known primarily through shabda-pramana (testimony) and anumana (inference from social patterns): the diaspora narrator infers what the village is like from what people say about it and from the general patterns of rural Mithila life. The two epistemological modes - direct perception versus testimony-and-inference - correspond to the two literary forms: lyric poetry (direct, perceptual, immediate) versus novel (indirect, testimonial, inferential).

## 4.4 Marginality and Recognition: Structural Comparisons

Both writers occupy marginal positions within the Maithili literary establishment, but for structurally different reasons. Buch's marginality is internal: he was a Bihar government employee, living in Kariyan, unconnected to Patna's literary networks and the Darbhanga establishment's cultural machinery. Pathak's marginality is geographical: he was a journalist in Guwahati, operating at the edge of the Maithili literary world's institutional geography.

Both marginalites are documented and theorised by the Videha Parallel History. Buch's case exemplifies what the Parallel History calls the "curse" of

institutional invisibility - the systematic exclusion of non-networked, non-Brahmin, non-Darbhanga voices from the canon. Pathak's case exemplifies what the Parallel History's diaspora sections document: the cultural productivity of Maithili communities outside Bihar, whose contribution to the language's survival and development in the Northeast is rarely acknowledged by the Patna-centric literary establishment.

# PART V: NAVYA-NYĀYA DEEP APPLICATION

## 5.1 Gangesa's Village, Buch's Village: The Epistemological Homecoming

The biographical coincidence is too significant to ignore: Kalikant Jha 'Buch' was born in Kariyan (Kariyon) - the same village as Gangesa Upadhyaya (fl. 1325 CE), author of the Tattvacintamani and founder of Navya-Nyaya. This is not merely a biographical footnote but an epistemological one: the greatest systematic epistemologist in India's history and one of the most gifted (and most neglected) Maithili poets of the 20th century share a birthplace.

The Videha Parallel History's Part 16 (on Gangesa Upadhyaya) documents the suppressed biographical details from the Dooshan Panji: Gangesa's birth anomaly (born five years after his father's death) and his marriage to a Charmkarini (woman from the leather-tanning caste). Buch's biographical curse - no recognition during lifetime, posthumous publication only - recapitulates Gangesa's suppressed personal history in a different register: both were exceptional minds whose full human reality was denied by the brahminical social-literary order.

The Navya-Nyaya's pramana-centred epistemology demands that all knowledge-claims be validated through proper means of knowledge. Applied to Buch's poetry: the claim that Buch is a major Maithili poet must be validated through pratyaksha (direct reading of the poems), anumana (inference from the quality of the poetic technique), upamana (comparison with acknowledged major Maithili poets), and shabda (testimony of authoritative critics like Ravi Bhushan Pathak). All four pramanas converge on the same conclusion: Buch is a major poet who was institutionally suppressed.

## 5.2 Vyāpti and the Novel: Pathak's Knowledge-Claims about Diaspora Life

Satyanand Pathak's novel makes an implicit claim: the diaspora Maithili's relationship to the village is characterised by a permanent tension between presence and absence. This is a vyāpti claim - an assertion of invariable concomitance between the diaspora condition (hetu) and the longing-for-origin (sadhya).

The Anumana-Khanda of the Tattvacintamani demands that vyāpti be established through parishodhana (repeated verification). Pathak's novel's serial publication history - first in Purvanchar Maithil, then expanded and published as a book, with multiple episodes of community feedback - represents precisely this parishodhana process. The diaspora community's enthusiastic response (multiple letters from Mithilanchal, phone calls from across Northeast India) validates the vyāpti claim: the novel does accurately represent the invariable emotional concomitance of diaspora life.

The avacchedaka analysis is critical here. The vyāpti holds specifically for: (a) Maithili diaspora in Northeast India; (b) of first-to-second generation; (c) living in urban centres (Guwahati, Siliguri, Calcutta); (d) maintaining cultural connection through periodic village-return. Outside these avacchedakas (limiters), the vyāpti may not hold - third-generation diaspora in the US or UK may have a completely different relationship to the origin-village. The novel's epistemological honesty lies in implicitly acknowledging these limits.

## 5.3 Shabda-Pramana and the Folk-Knowledge System

Both Buch and Pathak deploy folk-knowledge (lok-gyaan) as a form of shabda-pramana - verbal testimony validated by community tradition. Buch's poems draw on the folk music traditions of Mithila (Maheshvani, Chait thumri, Holi, Nachari) as repositories of shared emotional and spiritual knowledge. Pathak's novel deploys the crow-omen as a folk-epistemological moment: the grandmother's interpretation of the crow's caw is a shabda-pramana whose validity is grounded in the community's accumulated experiential tradition.

Gangesa's Shabda-Khanda acknowledges that not all verbal testimony is the testimony of an individual speaker: some testimony is the distilled wisdom of a tradition (the agama tradition, the Vedic testimony). Folk-knowledge systems - like Mithila's omen-reading - operate on this principle: the crow-interpretation is valid not because any single grandmother says so but because generations of Maithili experience have established the omen's reliability. Both Buch and Pathak take this folk-shabda-pramana seriously - neither ironises nor dismisses it, but neither accepts it uncritically. This is the correct epistemological stance: treating folk-knowledge as a genuine pramana while acknowledging its historically conditioned validity.

# PART VI: PARALLEL HISTORY POSITIONING

## 6.1 Buch in the Parallel History's Layers

The Videha Parallel History constructs its alternative archive in nine historical layers. Kalikant Jha 'Buch' belongs primarily to Layer 5 (Post-Independence Mithila, 1947–1983 - his death date) but his work is contemporaneous with the radical avant-garde of Rajkamal Chaudhary and the institutional crisis of the Sahitya Akademi's first Maithili awards (1966). The Parallel History's account of the 1967 unrewarded year - when no Sahitya Akademi award was given rather than give it to the satirist Harimohan Jha (1908–1984) - is directly relevant to Buch's case: the same institutional logic that kept Harimohan Jha without recognition during his most productive years kept Buch entirely invisible.

Buch's poetry, as documented in the Kalanidhi, engages with exactly the themes the Parallel History identifies as suppressed: subaltern social critique (the dowry system, administrative corruption, famine), folk-ecological poetry (the Kareh river poems), and the self-questioning of Maithili literary culture itself (the Vaagat Gaan's refusal to celebrate empty institutionalism).

## 6.2 Pathak and the Diaspora Dimension of the Parallel History

The Videha Parallel History explicitly recognises the Nepal Terai and the diaspora Maithili communities of Northeast India as equally central to the parallel tradition, not peripheral footnotes. Satyanand Pathak's Gaam Gel Chhalahun is the most significant novelistic document of the Northeast Indian Maithili diaspora's literary production in the post-Independence period.

The novel's publication context - Manorama Prakashan, Guwahati (wife as publisher; journalist as author; diaspora community as readership) - is precisely the kind of non-institutional, community-based literary production that the Parallel History celebrates over the Patna-centric, Sahitya Akademi-validated institutional model. Lakshmana Jha 'Sagar' - mentioned in the novel's acknowledgements as a mentor and guide - is himself the subject of Videha's Parallel History Part 49, confirming the network connections between Pathak's work and the broader Parallel History project.

## 6.3 The Digital Afterlife: Videha's Archive

Both works are documented in the Videha digital ecosystem. Kalanidhi appears in the Videha Google Books / Videha Pothi archive, listed alongside canonical modern Maithili texts, confirming its status within the Parallel History's counter-canon. Gaam Gel Chhalahun is archived on videha.co.in/pothi.htm.

The Videha archive's curation of both works confirms the Parallel History's fundamental claim: a genuine history of Maithili literature must include the institutionally invisible poet of Kariyan (Buch) and the diaspora novelist of Guwahati (Pathak), alongside the Sahitya Akademi's certified canonical figures.

# PART VII: CONCLUSION AND CRITICAL ASSESSMENT

## 7.1 Summary of Findings

Kalikant Jha ‘Buch’ (Kalanidhi, 2010) emerges from this study as one of the most significant and unjustly neglected poets in 20th-century Maithili literature. His 98 poems demonstrate: a mastery of the synthesis of contradictory emotions (Empson’s ambiguity; Abhinavagupta’s rasa-theory); a commitment to abhidha (direct denotative language) as the primary vehicle of poetic power; a sophisticated engagement with Maithili’s folk musical traditions (22 identified raga-forms and folk genres); and a social-protest dimension that places him squarely within the Parallel History’s “democratic-spiritual” counter-tradition.

Satyanand Pathak’s Gaam Gel Chhalahun (2004) emerges as a foundational text of the Maithili diaspora novel. Its achievement is: the thematisation of diaspora memory through the pluperfect tense as narrative grammar; a sociologically grounded heteroglossia (Bakhtin) that represents the multiplicity of diaspora voices; the deployment of folk-omen as a genuine epistemological form (Gangesa’s shabda-pramana); and its community-based, non-institutional publication as an embodiment of the Parallel History’s values.

## 7.2 The Navya-Nyaya Verdict

Applying Gangesa’s four-pramana framework as a meta-critical methodology: the knowledge-claim that both these writers are significant figures deserving critical recognition is validated by all four means of valid knowledge. Pratyaksha: direct reading of the texts confirms their literary quality. Anumana: inference from the quality of the poetic and narrative technique validates the claim of significance. Upamana: comparison with acknowledged major Maithili writers (Vidyapati, Rajkamal Chaudhary, Harimohan Jha) places both writers within reach of the highest tier of Maithili literary achievement. Shabda: the testimony of authoritative critics (Ravi Bhushan Pathak on Buch; Lakshmana Jha ‘Sagar’ and the diaspora community on Pathak) validates the claim through expert testimony.

The avacchedaka principle reminds us that these claims must be properly limited: Buch is specifically a Maithili poet of the post-Independence period, working in the lyric-song tradition, from a non-institutional subaltern position.

Pathak is specifically a novelist of the Maithili Northeast diaspora, writing in the social-realist mode, from a journalist-diaspora position. Overgeneralising these limited claims (avacchedakas) would produce defective literary knowledge - precisely the kind of defective knowledge that the institutionalised canon produces when it ignores these limiters.

## 7.3 Final Assessment

The critical tragedy of Kalikant Jha ‘Buch’ - a poet of the highest order who died without publishing a single book - is not an individual failure but a systemic indictment of the Maithili literary establishment. The Kalanidhi’s posthumous publication is both a rescue and a reproach. The Videha Parallel History’s inclusion of Kalanidhi in its digital archive is the most appropriate institutional response - not as charity to a minor figure but as the belated correction of a major wrong.

Satyanand Pathak’s Gaam Gel Chhalahun stands as the most fully realised fictional account of what it means to be Maithili and displaced: to carry a language, a culture, a set of omens and songs into a city that does not know them, and to sustain them not through academic effort but through the living tissue of community memory. As the novel’s title suggests, the village is always in the pluperfect - already gone, yet always there, conditioning every present moment of diaspora existence.

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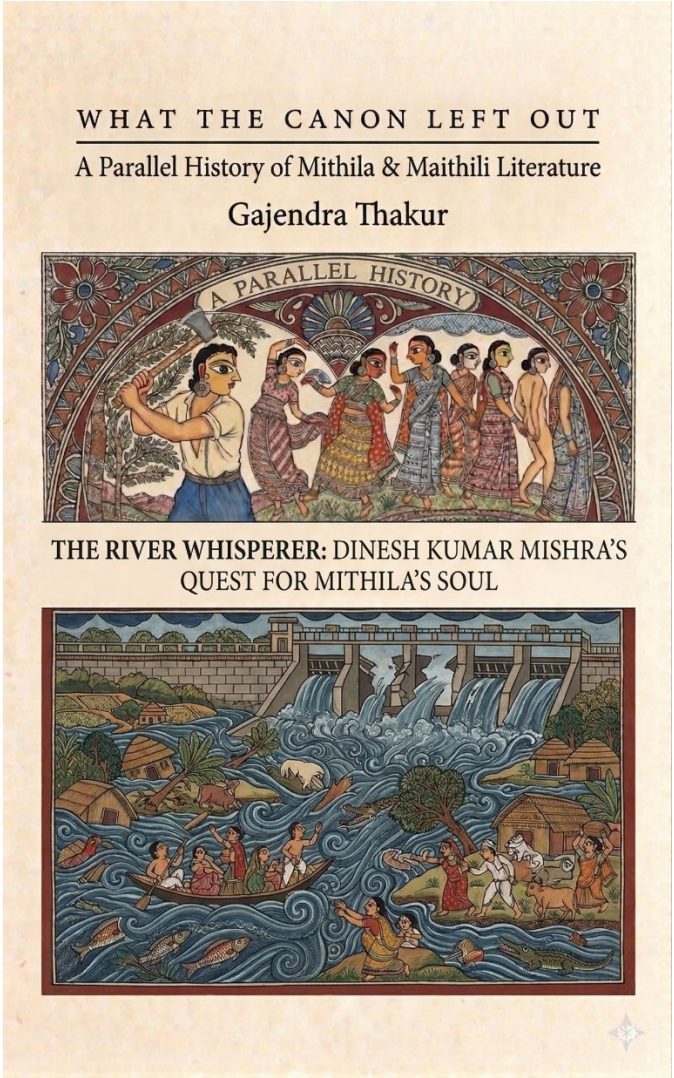
*All source books are available at videha.co.in/pothi.htm and through the Videha Parallel History series at videha.co.in/gajenthakur.htm. Primary evidence is drawn from the two books (Kalanidhi; Gaam Gel Chhalahun), supplemented by web research from Videha, the Hum Mithilawasi literary documentation blog, and the Videha Google Books Pothi archive.*

**LESSON 022 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**




# EVER NEW DINESH KUMAR MISHRA

NIT NAVAL DINESH KUMAR MISHRA

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Author's Introduction and Scholarly Philosophical Background

Dinesh Kumar Mishra's personality and work are an achievement in the discourse on rivers in Bihar. He was born in 1946 in Azamgarh, Uttar Pradesh, but his field of work was the floodplains of the Kosi, Kamla, Bagmati, and Gandak rivers in Bihar. A graduate (1968) and postgraduate (1970) in Civil Engineering from IIT Kharagpur, Mishra ji's perspective, while deeply technical, is also profoundly imbued with human sensitivity. In 2006, he obtained a Ph.D. from South Gujarat University. His doctoral research was also based on the historical and technical aspects of floods and water management.

His journey into flood research began in 1984 after the Saharsa section of the Kosi embankment broke. Witnessing the plight of the displaced people there, he decided to document the history of floods and droughts in Bihar. Mishra ji believes that embankments and dams are not sufficient to stop floods; rather, they often exacerbate the catastrophe. He has worked with over 700 village groups through the 'Flood Liberation Movement' (BMA), whom he calls 'flood historians'. Mishra ji's main argument is that the current 'top-heavy' flood control policy has failed. He advocates for the restoration of traditional water management systems and the cultural ownership of the people.

Dinesh Kumar Mishra is introduced as an engineer trained at IIT Kharagpur, but his identity is more firmly established as a 'historian' and 'folk engineer' of Mithila's rivers. His research journey began in 1984 after the breach of the Kosi embankment at Hempur village in the Nauhatta block of Saharsa district.

While working in Saharsa at that time, Mishra ji experienced that the measures taken for flood control (embankments), which were built to protect the people, had not reduced the devastation of floods but had actually made it more severe. "Bagavat Par Majboor Mithila Ki Kamla Nadi" is the essence of that ideological shift, where he advocates for local traditional knowledge instead of technical hubris.

This book by Dinesh Kumar Mishra is not a government report, but rather a cry from the soil of Mithila. He emphasizes traditional flood management (where river water was allowed to spread by diverting it). He believes that if engineering only diverts the flow of water instead of removing sand, it is nothing more than "technical exorcism." Ultimately, the river itself renders the final judgment.

The rivers hold a central place in the geographical, cultural, and economic structure of North Bihar. Numerous streams originating from the Himalayas give both fertility and destruction to the plains of Mithila. In this context, "Bhutahi Balan" is not just the name of a river, but a living document of an ecological crisis and governmental failure. Dr. Dinesh Kumar Mishra, who dedicated his entire life to the study and public dialogue on the rivers of North Bihar, presents in his work "Bhutahi Balan: Story of a Ghost River and

Engineering Witchcraft" a serious critique of the water policy of this region. This report presents a detailed analysis of the historical, geographical, and sociological aspects of Bhutahi Balan in the light of Dinesh Kumar Mishra's research, experience, and the interconnections of folk life in Mithila.

Understanding the personality and work of Dr. Dinesh Kumar Mishra is essential for understanding the river discourse in North Bihar. Born in a village in Uttar Pradesh in 1948, Dr. Mishra began his career as an engineer, but his mind remained engaged in exploring the untouched aspects of rivers. After graduating in Civil Engineering from IIT Kharagpur in 1968, he did not limit his research to just concrete and iron. He felt that the modern engineering paradigm imposed on North Bihar is contrary to the nature of the rivers.

Forty years of research into newspapers at the National Library in Kolkata and the study of legislative debates were decisive in his intellectual development. This led to his first book, "Those Afflicted by Flood", inspired by which he left his professional career to become a full-time river activist and researcher. Dr. Mishra is often called a "walking encyclopedia of Bihar's rivers", because his knowledge is not just bookish, but is embedded in village folklore, songs, myths, and poetry. He is a polyglot scholar who can converse fluently in Maithili, Hindi, English, Bengali, Odia, and Urdu.

Dr. Mishra's greatest contribution is the establishment of the "Flood Liberation Movement" (BMA), a network of over 700 villages' "flood historians". This organization teaches people how their ancestors lived in harmony with floods before the construction of embankments. His research has been awarded the Ashoka Fellowship and several prestigious honors.

The literature composed by Dr. Mishra can be called the 'biography' of every major river in North Bihar. His writing style is a unique confluence of technical precision and human sensitivity.

The land of Mithila has been struggling with the devastation of floods. The Kushweshwarsthan area often gets submerged even without floods, simply during the rainy season. But this situation is post-1978-79. Earlier that region was completely fertile, but with the unbridled construction of embankments in India, water started accumulating there. However, no news of floods from that area ever comes; if it does, it is only propaganda that this water is a collection of water released from Nepal. The people of the Kushweshwarsthan area have learned the art of dealing with this new crisis. I recall the scene when, during a flood, I was asked to come from Kushweshwarsthan to Mahishi Ugratarasthan because it was easier to travel by boat at that time – it was said. During the khutta-chabchacha season, boats cannot operate, and the condition of the roads is beyond question. The pattern of crops changed; somehow, through practices like fishing, this region forcibly learned a new life skill. The 2008 calamity of Kaushiki (Kosi) was able to end this propaganda. Previously, we all saw who controls the two barrages in Nepal on the Kosi and Gandak? This control lies with the Water Resources Department of the Bihar government, and engineers of the Bihar government have control here. The decision to release water is in the hands of the Water Resources Department of the Bihar government. Nepal would have the right to release water only if a dam/embankment were built on some other channel, but even after more than 50 years, no agreement has been possible between the two countries. Why? The Bhimnagar Barrage on the Kosi, in Kushaha, Nepal, was built in 1958. Its lifespan was fixed at 30 years, which ended in 1988. Why couldn't an agreement be reached between the two countries? The sand accumulating in the middle of the dam is removed every year. If not removed, its height keeps increasing, then the height of the embankment has to be increased every year. In the year this work is not started on time, a catastrophe occurs that year. The same happened in 2008; the rains started, and on August 18th, a 2-meter crack appeared in the Kosi embankment. I have seen the 1987 flood with my own eyes. Near the Jhajharpur embankment, water overflowed from one place, and right before my eyes, I saw how a 1-meter crack turned into a kilometer. By August 27-28, 2008, this breach at the Bhimnagar Barrage had become 2 kilometers. The reason was the Kosi leaving its main channel, taking a new course, and devastating Mithilanchal in Nepal along with Mithilanchal in Bihar. NASA images from August 8, 2008, and August 24, 2008, showed a distance of 200 kilometers between the Kosi's new and old channels. The Bhimnagar Barrage had now become a barrage built on a tributary of the Kosi. When a disaster strikes a state, it requests assistance from the center. A central minister's team tours the state and submits a report, based on which another central minister's team decides

whether this disaster is a national disaster or not. While the politicians of Bihar, forgetting their own fifty years of failure, started accusing each other, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh toured the area and declared it a national disaster. Because this was a level-three disaster and for the concerned state – neither in terms of finance nor in terms of relief management capability – it was impossible to cope. Then assistance was given from the National Contingency Disaster Fund, and farmers' loans were also waived. The disaster at Kusheshwar Sthan comes every year, and it gets forgotten each time. Why projects like the Damodar Valley and Mayurakshi were not possible on the Kosi, Kamla, Bhutahi Balan, Gandak, Burhi Gandak, and Bagmati? Why is Visvesvaraya's Vrindavan Dam successful? How long will we keep deceiving the public by blaming the Nepal government? The only solution is to break and remove the earthen embankments built on Kamla-Balan etc. with large machinery and construct pucca canals instead of kutcha ones. A quick solution should be reached by talking with the Nepal government. And until that happens, whatever short-term measures are available should be done, like removing the sand between the embankments before the rains, carry out embankment repair work beforehand instead of waiting for the rains to come, and keep political ambitions away from all this. To bring the Kosi back to its old course, many embankments would have to be built, and they can never be a solution. Learn from the benefits and harms of the Kamla channel's canals. On one hand, a kutcha canal and on top of that, fundamental design issues; one example is enough for all such haphazardly built projects. The main canal taken out from the Kamla current towards the west is in the direction from Jaynagar to Umrao – east to west. But there, the slope of the land is from north to south. What would be the result during the rainy season? What is the result? This embankment gets built, and water accumulates to its north. Every year, due to this canal-like embankment, whether Patna gets flooded or not, the crops in the northern side are definitely destroyed. The direction of the canal is changed so that Mr. So-and-so's land is not taken into the canal! Embankment was constructed on the Kamla river from Jaynagar to Jhajharpur in 1960, and this started the devastation of the entire area. The condition of the area beyond Jhajharpur is clear from the description of Kusheshwar. The stories of Madhepura, Ghanshyampur, Singhia are no different from Kusheshwar. As sand filled up between the two embankments of Kamla-Balan, everything was destroyed within twenty years of the construction of these embankments. The Kamla current, which merged with Balan near Pipraghat in 1954, due to a large log obstruction flowing from the Himalayas. Now, the situation is such that the water level in this current can rise by more than 2 meters in ten hours. From

1965 onwards, so much sand filled between the embankments that it became necessary to increase their height, and demands started that the embankments be broken! The Kosi's water comes from Mount Everest, Kanchenjunga, Gauri-Shankar peaks, and the Makalu mountain range. In Nepal, it is the Saptakoshi, which includes the Indravati, Sunkosi (Bhot Kosi), Tamba Kosi, Likhu Kosi, Dudh Kosi, Arun Kosi, and Tamar Kosi. Among these, Indravati, Sunkosi, Tamba Kosi, Likhu Kosi, and Dudh Kosi combine to form the Sunkosi, which flows roughly from west to east; its branches roughly flow from north to south. These five currents bring water from the Gauri Shankar peak and the Makalu mountain range. The Arun Kosi receives water from the Mount Everest (Sagarmatha) region. This current flows roughly north-south. The Tamar Kosi flows roughly east-west and receives its water from the Kanchenjunga mountain range. Now these three branches – Sunkosi, Arun Kosi, and Tamar Kosi – meet at Triveni in Dhankuta district to form the Saptakoshi. Ten kilometers further downstream is Chatra, where the Mahakosi, Saptakoshi, or Kosi emerges onto the plains. Now, flowing north-south, the North Kosi, after about fifty kilometers in Nepal, enters India near Hanumannagar-Bhimnagar, and after turning somewhat south-west, it takes a south-east and west-east direction and flows about 130 km in India before merging with the Ganga near Kursela. The Bagmati and Kamla currents also join the Kosi at the confluence of Saharsa-Darbhanga-Purnia districts. The first dam on the Kosi was the 'Vir-Bandh' built in the 12th century by Lakshmana II, whose remnants are still present south of Bhimnagar. With the construction of the barrage near Bhimnagar, the Eastern Kosi embankment and the Eastern Kosi canal were also built. The Kunwar Sen Commission in 1966 proposed a plan for a barrage at Dgarmara, 23 km downstream from Bhimnagar, for Kosi control, which got lost in debate and politics. There were two advantages to this barrage. Firstly, if the life of the Bhimnagar Barrage ended, this barrage could function; secondly, it would develop inland water transport from Uttar Pradesh to Assam, which would greatly benefit North Bihar. However, the central irrigation minister, Dr. K.L. Rao, did not allocate funds for the construction of this barrage. The Western Kosi Canal was started as an alternative at a slow pace, but work on it is still ongoing. Nothing could be done for the Kosi. Ideas came, plans were rejected. For as many days as the work was supposed to be completed, disputes continued for that many days; a cheaper plan was approved instead of the Dgarmara Barrage plan, but even that kept waiting for completion! In this, Visvesvaraya comes to mind. A dam was built on the Musi and its tributaries, located about 16 miles from Hyderabad, and a tributary of the Musi was built 6.5 miles from the city. Along with that, embankments were built on both sides

of the river in the city. When the proposed plan for the 130-foot high Krishnaraja Sagar Dam was sent by the Mysore state to the English, Viceroy Hardinge reduced it to 80 feet. Visvesvaraya compensated for this by increasing the width of the lower part. When a flood came in between, he compensated for the lost time by employing extra laborers, treating malaria and other diseased laborers, hiring doctors, installing Washington lamps at night, and through personal supervision. Such was the patriot that he did not import cement; instead, he built the dam using 'surkhi' made by mixing sand, calcium, stone, and burnt brick powder. Before the dam's construction, a two-tiered canal system was built. It is necessary that funds from the Prime Minister's Disaster Fund and the Chief Minister's Disaster Fund are not wasted; simultaneously, pressure should be put on the government to declare holidays during floods instead of during the summer heat. Let alone CBSE and ICSE, even the Bihar Board has not been able to do this. The Dgarmara Barrage plan in India should be initiated, because the Bhimnagar Barrage has completed its lifespan. Funds for this should be taken from both the Railway and Road Ministries because a rail and road can also be built on it, and should be. During the period of barrage construction, pucca canals should be built according to the slope of the land. All kutcha embankments should be broken and removed, and pucca embankments should be made motorable, with adequate trees planted on both sides of the embankment. Just as road projects in Bihar are being realized like a dream, similarly, removing all obstacles, work on all these should be started on a war footing. If the embankment started in the 12th century had been completed, rivers could have become the servants of humanity.

Now presented is a summary of Dinesh Kumar Mishra ji's research, in Maithili, from time to time...

Bandini Mahananda (1994)

Bandini Mahananda (1994)

Whenever the glorious past of India is discussed, Bihar's name is taken first. When gods and demons churned the ocean together, Mount Mandara was used for the churning. This place likely falls in present-day Bhagalpur district; perhaps the sea's boundary extended till here then. Stories of this region have

been heard since the time of King Janaka. Bihar has always prided itself on scholars and artisans like Yajnavalkya, Gautama, Chyavana, Shrungi, Vishvamitra, Ashtavakra, Katyayana, Patanjali, Varsha, Upavarsha, Panini, Ashvaghosha, Vatsyayana, Aryabhata, and Varahamihira. In ancient times, Mithila was a major center of culture, education, art, and literature, attracting scholars from different parts of the country. Lord Mahavira gave the teachings of love, compassion, harmony, and tolerance to the whole world from this land. It was here that Prince Siddhartha became Lord Buddha, whose words reached the entire world. In the Valmiki Ramayana, Lord Rama went to Janakpur with his brothers Lakshmana, Bharata, and Shatrughna for marriage. On this journey, he killed Taraka near Buxar and went to Janakpur via Siddhashrama, Ahalya-Ashram, Gautama Ashram, and Vaishali. During the Mahabharata period, Jarasandha's capital was in present-day Rajgriha, and Karna's Anga Desh capital was Champanagari (Bhagalpur). Much of the Pandavas' exile and secret stay was spent in the forests of Purnia. Bhima had once conquered Modagiri (present-day Munger), and the Bhima Bandh near Kharagpur Haveli is considered associated with him. It is said about the Harihar Kshetra near Sonpur (Chapra) that Lord Vishnu once brought many cows here under the leadership of Pashupati Nandi. Hence, the place was named Harihar Kshetra. A fight occurred here between an elephant and a crocodile, and Lord Vishnu himself had to come to save the elephant with bare feet, without his mount Garuda.

In historical times, the description of Bihar perhaps starts with Bimbisara of Magadha (6th century BCE), and it is believed that Lord Vardhamana Mahavira and Lord Buddha emerged during this period. Around this time, the Licchavi kingdom in Vaishali was at its zenith. After the fall of the Nanda dynasty, the Mauryan empire was established in Magadha by Chandragupta Maurya in 321 BCE. Chanakya (Kautilya) played a crucial role in the rise of Chandragupta Maurya. There is some disagreement about Chanakya's native place. Some believe he was from Taxila, while according to another belief, Chanakya was a resident of present-day West Champaran. Another important name of the Mauryan dynasty is Emperor Ashoka (272-232 BCE), who, after conquering Kalinga, became disillusioned with war and brutality and spent the rest of his life propagating Buddhism. Pushyamitra assassinated the last Mauryan emperor Brihadratha in 187 BCE, followed by Greeks, Shakas, Kushanas, etc., who ruled Magadha until 320 CE, when Chandragupta established the Gupta Empire in Pataliputra. The Gupta kings – Chandragupta, Samudragupta,

Chandragupta Vikramaditya – once again restored Magadha's old glory. However, the Huna invasions in the late 5th century again disrupted Magadha's prosperity, and the Hunas remained in the region until the mid-7th century, when Harshavardhana captured Pataliputra in 641 CE. But this was not permanent. It remained under this rule until the 8th century, and after the Gupta dynasty, the Pala dynasty ruled Pataliputra until the early 12th century. Indradyumna was the last king of this dynasty. Bakhtiyar Khilji attacked Magadha during his time. Any mention of Bihar is incomplete without mentioning Nalanda and Vikramashila universities. The Chinese traveler Fa-Hien, who stayed in India between 405-411 CE, described the Nalanda Buddhist Vihara in his writings but is silent about the university. However, Hiuen-Tsang (lived in India 630-643 CE) certainly praised the academic glory of Nalanda. This university has been highly praised for its academic excellence from various parts of the country. About ten thousand students from various corners of the country and abroad lived and studied at this university. Subjects like grammar, law, literature, philosophy, etc., were taught there. Any student seeking admission had to take an examination at the gate, and only after satisfaction was the student admitted. This university was established by Gupta kings in the 5th century and was kept under royal patronage. Legend has it that Nalanda University was built by Emperor Ashoka, but there is no proof of this. Vikramashila University was established by Pala kings in the 8th century in the Patharghat mountains, about 40 kilometers southeast of present-day Bhagalpur. The chief acharya of this university, Atish Shrijnan Dipankar, became very famous and was invited to Tibet in the 11th century by the Tibetan king to propagate Dharma. This university had 108 acharyas, and eight thousand people could sit together and listen to religious discussions in its hall. Subjects like Vedas, Vedanta, Sankhyayoga, Mimamsa, Buddhist philosophy, etc., were taught there. However, in 1206 CE, when the Tibetan Buddhist monk pilgrim Dharmaswami came to this region, he saw only ruins of this university. Besides these two universities, Odantapuri Vihara (present-day Bihar Sharif) near Nalanda existed. This vihara was established by Pala kings in the 9th century but could never compete with Nalanda or Vikramashila. Similarly, in the 8th century, a debate took place between Adi Shankaracharya and Mandan Mishra in Mahishi (present-day Saharsa). The mediation was done by Mandan Mishra's erudite wife, Bharati. Mandan Mishra lost the debate, but Bharati herself debated Shankaracharya and forced him to ask for time for further study. There is a dispute about whether this Mahishi is the same Mahishmati where the Shastrartha between Shankaracharya and Mandan Mishra took place. In the scholar tradition of Mithila, Bhanudatta Mishra, Ratneshwar, Jyotishwar,

Bhagadatta, Prithvidhara Acharya, Gangesha Upadhyaya, Jagadhara, Vidyapati, Shankara Mishra, Vachaspati Mishra, and Prabhakara Mishra are prominent. Vidyapati is embedded in every home in Mithila. He also guided all of Hindi and Bengali literature. The scholarly women of Mithila were in no way behind men. Besides Rishi Maitreyi and Gargi, in the 15th century, Lakhima Devi, Lakhia Devi, Vishwas Devi, and Chandrakala Devi did unprecedented work in literature and philosophy.

In the late 12th century, Afghan and Turk attacks began on Bihar. Bakhtiyar Khilji seized the territory from the Pala kings, leading to a period of administrative instability. Governance was under the Sultan of Delhi, sometimes Agra, sometimes Jaunpur, or Gaur (Bengal). However, none could control all of Bihar, and their rule continued in different parts. In this sequence, many emperors came, from Qutb-ud-din Aibak, Sultan Ghiyasuddin, Firoz Shah to Sikandar Lodhi. Sher Shah (1540-1545) was the only ruler who attempted to establish his empire systematically. Sher Shah wanted to restore Patna to its old glory and worked in that direction. He moved the capital from Bihar Sharif, which had been running since Bakhtiyar Khilji's time, to Patna and built a new fort. He expanded his kingdom's boundaries to Jodhpur, Gwalior, Malwa, and Ranthambore and re-established a system of good governance. Sher Shah is credited with building roads from Bengal to Punjab. But the rising power of the Mughals could not be handled by Sher Shah's successors, and during Akbar's time, Bihar came under Mughal control. The kings/jagirdars of Bihar did not accept these external powers normally. During the reign of Aurangzeb's grandson, Azim-ush-Shan, the glory of Azimabad (this city was built by Azim-ush-Shan and is now considered the area of present-day Patna city) increased, and trade between Patna and Bengal grew. Murshid Quli Khan became the ruler of Bengal in 1704, and after Aurangzeb's death in 1707, Azimabad came under his control. In 1740, Alivardi Khan took over control in Murshidabad, and subsequently, governance passed into the hands of Zain-ud-Din Ahmed and Siraj-ud-Daulah, who were killed by the English. After that, Mir Jafar and Mir Qasim Ali became rulers. They did not last long, and the English consolidated their empire in 1765. Neither the Afghans, Turks, nor Mughal rulers stayed easily in Bihar, nor did they let the English stay. In 1857, Babu Kunwar Singh and Babu Amar Singh of Jagdishpur revolted against the English. In this sequence, Babu Kunwar Singh had to flee to Azamgarh once, but he returned bravely and accepted death instead of slavery in April 1858. Later, Babu Amar Singh also did the same. On the other side, Siddhu-Kanhu,

Chand, and Bhairav brothers of Santhal Pargana raised the flag of rebellion against British rule in South Bihar between 1855-57, and then Birsa Bhagwan kept the fire of unrest burning in the forests of Chotanagpur between 1895-2000. Along with them, the name of Tilka Manjhi is also taken with great reverence. In 1908, Khudiram Bose and Prafulla Chaki threw a bomb at the infamous Bengal collector Kingsford in Muzaffarpur. The collector survived, but Prafulla Chaki committed suicide before being caught, and the young Khudiram Bose was hanged. In April 1917, at the insistence of Rajkumar Shukla, a farmer from Champaran, Mahatma Gandhi came to Champaran and first raised his voice against the atrocities of the British. After that, in the freedom movement, Bihar saw a series of many famous leaders like Braj Kishore Prasad, Dr. Rajendra Prasad, Shri Krishna Sinha, Anugrah Narayan Sinha, Vaidyanath Jha, Jayaprakash Narayan, and Babu Jagjivan Ram. Many scholars/freedom fighters made Bihar their workplace, including Acharya Kripalani, Mahapandit Rahul Sankrityayan, Shri Kashi Prasad Jaiswal, and Swami Sahajanand Saraswati. Where there were many movements in Bihar to gain freedom from foreign slavery, valiant poets flowing with the rich stream of literature were also born on this land from time to time. The compositions of Raja Radhika Raman Prasad Singh, Acharya Shivpujan Sahay, Acharya Nalin Vilochan Sharma, Shri Ramvriksh Benipuri, Shri Phanishwar Nath 'Renu', Rashtrakavi Ramdhari Singh 'Dinkar', Nagarjun, and Shad Azimabadi contain the scent and contemplation of the country's soil. Bihar (Patna) is the birthplace of Shri Guru Gobind Singh ji.

After the arrival of the British, Bihar was administered from Calcutta. Since the 1857 revolt, there was a desire among people to see Bihar as a separate province. As a result of the movement led by Shri Sachchidananda Sinha, Babu Shaligram Singh, and Babu Visheshwar Singh, Bihar and Odisha became a separate state in April 1912. Odisha also separated from Bihar in April 1936. Based on the recommendations of the State Reorganisation Commission in the 1950s, Bihar acquired its current geographical form. Surrounded by West Bengal to the east, Uttar Pradesh to the west, Madhya Pradesh and Odisha to the south, and Nepal to the north, this state is divided by the Ganga river flowing from west to east.

Geographically, Bihar is divided into three parts.

The first is the Ganga region of North Bihar. Twenty districts of Bihar fall in this plain area, situated between the Terai of Nepal and the northern bank of the Gandak. Additionally, the Naugachhia sub-division of Bhagalpur district falls in North Bihar. This entire area is famous as North Bihar. Due to being filled with plains and rivers, North Bihar has been very rich from an agricultural perspective.

Central Bihar (now South Bihar) – The plain on the southern bank of the Gandak in Bihar is Central Bihar. Covered by currents like Durgavati, Karmanasa, Son, Punpun, Phalgu, etc., this area's land is as fertile as North Bihar. The Kaimur range has hills without trees, just stones, in this region. Central Bihar's economy is based on farming.

Chotanagpur region (now Jharkhand) – The south-eastern area of the Gandak valley in Bihar is surrounded by plateaus and forests, and more than a third of India's total mineral wealth is buried under these forests, hills, and land. This region of the Barakar, Damodar, Subarnarekha, Kiul, Koel, Auranga, Amanat, Kanhar, Ajay, and Mayurakshi currents, Chotanagpur and Santhal Pargana, is very rich from an industrial perspective. Coal, iron, manganese, mica, steatite, limestone, fireclay, china clay, kainite, copper, bauxite, asbestos, dolomite, quartz, uranium, etc., are found in this region. That is why there are several large industries in this area. TISCO and TELCO of the Tata group in Jamshedpur, the steel plant in Bokaro, Heavy Engineering Corporation in Ranchi, the aluminum plant in Muri (Ranchi), Hindustan Copper Corporation in East Singhbhum, the Chemical Fertilizer Plant in Sindri, the Dhanbad-Jharia coal mines, zinc plants at Jhingapani, Khelari, and cement factories in Jamshedpur are all established in this region. Despite having such fertile land, vast water resources, and incomparable mineral wealth, Bihar is lagging in all established parameters of development compared to other states of the country.

Bihar – A Backward Present: If Bihar is poor despite such natural resources, who should be blamed? The frustration arising from centuries of subjugation or administrative, political, and social mismanagement. As the economy is primarily based on agriculture, it is clearly understood that if farming is somehow well-managed, then the people of Bihar could remain connected to the land. The problem is the ownership rights of land. Here, 84.6 percent of cultivators own only 37.7 percent of the land. The average holding size among

them is not more than 2 hectares. On the other hand, 15.4 percent of people own 63.3 percent of the land. This means that if there is any disruption in farming, the livelihood of many is at stake. Bihar's agriculture depends on rainfall, or on God. Bihar is almost always hit by drought or flood every year. Sometimes both come together. Sometimes there is drought in one area and flood in another, or first drought and then flood in the same place, or first flood and then drought. All forms of these two problems are devastating. Due to the geographical structure of Bihar, with rivers on all sides and the plateau region of South Bihar, there is a possibility of drought in the south and flood in the north. Conditions in Central Bihar keep changing. Due to the Son canal, some farming is managed in districts like Patna, Ara, Rohtas, Bhojpur, Bhabhua, etc., but floods often occur in these districts as well. The other districts of Central Bihar – Gaya, Jehanabad, Nalanda, Nawada, Gaya, and Aurangabad – are more often hit by drought.

Flood and Bihar: I want to limit my study to floods in Bihar. According to the report of the National Flood Commission (1980), Bihar's share in the damage caused by floods in the country is 22.8 percent. Only 16.55 percent of the total area affected by floods in the country falls in Bihar. Meaning, a relatively smaller area in Bihar suffers greater damage. After the publication of the National Flood Commission's (1980) report, major floods occurred in Bihar in 1984, 1987, and 1993, among which the 1987 flood is considered devastating. This flood increased Bihar's status regarding floods in the entire country. According to a report, Bihar is the most flood-affected state in India. Out of the total 40 million hectares of flood-affected area in the country, 6.461 million hectares are in Bihar. This is 16 percent of the country's total flood-affected area. This is 37 percent of Bihar's geographical area, which is 17.350 million hectares. In terms of population, 56.5 percent of the total flood-affected population resides in Bihar state. This fact has also been acknowledged by the National Flood Commission. The total area of North Bihar is 5.851 million hectares. In this part, 4.447 million hectares area is flood-affected. Thus, about 76 percent of North Bihar is flood-affected.

If we take literacy as the only parameter to measure the quality of life, the condition of North Bihar is the most pitiable even in the context of Bihar. Here, the literacy percentage is lower than Bihar's. Similarly, another example of per capita electricity consumption – in 1978-79, 1980-81, and 1981-82, the per capita electricity consumption in the country was 150.73 kW, 155.62 kW, and 143.41 kW respectively. On the other hand, during this period, Bihar's per

capita consumption was 87.15 kW, 82.58 kW, and 81.13 kW respectively. If North Bihar is looked at separately, during this period, per capita electricity consumption there was 26.60 kW, 1482 kW, and 13.43 kW respectively, meaning less than one-tenth of the national average is available in North Bihar. Besides, currently, about 0.9 million hectares of land in Bihar are affected by water erosion, and all these areas are in North Bihar, for which the soil composition and annual floods in this region are responsible. Excessive water erosion has adversely affected both agricultural production and employment related to agriculture, and the economic crisis has deepened.

The main rivers are Ghaghra, Gandak, Burhi Gandak, Bagmati, the Adhwara group, Kamla, Kosi, Mahananda. All these rivers are known for changing their course, among which the Kosi current is the most shifting. The only way to drain water from this entire area is through the Ganga, and this river acts as a lifeline for the entire province.

Ganga: Except for the Subarnarekha valley in South Bihar, the rest of Bihar's water drains through the Ganga, so the Ganga becomes very important. Bihar is also not less important for the Ganga. One name of the Ganga is Jahnavi. Near Sultanpur in modern Bhagalpur, there is a temple of Lord Shankar on a hill in the Ganga's current. It is said that sage Jahnu had his hermitage here. When Bhagiratha convinced Ganga to follow him to the hermitage of Kapila Muni to liberate his ancestors, Ganga followed him, and whatever came in her way, she left her mark on it. But now the competition was with sage Jahnu, whose hermitage Ganga was supposed to flow through. Seeing the flow of the Gandak, the sage became angry and drank up the Ganga. Poor Bhagiratha somehow convinced the sage to release Ganga, then he released Ganga from his stomach. Hence the Ganga got the name Jahnavi.

The Ganga current originates from the Gangotri Glacier at an altitude of 7,016 meters in the Uttarkashi district of Uttar Pradesh. Originally, this current is called Bhagirathi, which after its confluence with the Alaknanda near Dev Prayag, takes the name Ganga and after flowing about 250 km downstream, descends into the plains near Rishikesh. After that, this river flows through Haridwar, Kanpur, Varanasi, and enters Bihar at a distance of about 155 km. The total length of this current in Uttar Pradesh is about 1450 km, which includes the length of the Bhagirathi from Gangotri to Dev Prayag. The length

of this current in Bihar is about 438 km, of which it flows for 110 km forming the border between Uttar Pradesh and Bihar.

After leaving Bihar near Rajmahal, the Ganga splits into two parts 40 km east of Farakka, and these two currents get separate names. The left current, which goes east, is called Padma, and the right current named Bhagirathi flows south and, after branching into many currents through Murshidabad, Burdwan, 24 Parganas, Kolkata, meets the Bay of Bengal near Sagar Island. The total length of the Ganga in West Bengal is 520 km.

Where there is such a large and such a river, flood is no big deal. In fact, the structure of this region is such that flood and river course change are natural processes.

In the Somashwar hill area of West Champaran in North Bihar, due to the low slope of the land and rivers, rainwater does not drain easily and spreads over a large area. When the Ganga's level is high, the water of its tributaries also gets blocked. Due to the spread of water, new soil gets deposited in the fields on one hand, and the fertility of the land becomes refreshed. Sometimes if a severe flood comes, along with crops, a lot of life and property are also lost.

To understand this problem of floods in North Bihar, it is necessary to understand the formation process of the Ganga valley and also understand the different conditions of rain and water, called the hydrological cycle. Then one can understand how rivers change their course and then the form of the flood becomes clear.

Formation of the Ganga Valley: About 33.50 billion years ago, the earth separated from the sun as a sphere of fire. Then, large rocks were falling on its upper surface. Over time, heavy rocks sank into the earth. But the lighter rocks remained on top. The impact of earthquakes on these large rocks and the effect of gases emanating from them started the formation of the atmosphere. Slowly, as the earth cooled further, the water present in the atmosphere as vapor cooled down, turned into rain and snow, fell back onto the land, and due to such events for lakhs of years, the ocean was formed. Thus, the temperature on the earth's surface decreased, but the heat and upheaval inside the earth continued and

continue today. Today, the earth's crust is divided into many large, strong pieces, and many countries and continents are settled on them. But until about 300 million years ago, the earth's surface was not divided into such pieces. Until then, all islands or continents existed as one landmass. However, in the last 200 million years, not only have cracks appeared on the earth's surface, but the divided pieces also started moving, which are called plates. The expansion of these plates resulted in the present-day world. This process has not stopped. Even today, these plates keep rubbing against each other. One part climbs over another. So much is happening beneath our earth every moment, which sometimes manifests as an earthquake. According to an estimate, about 10,000 small and large earthquakes are recorded worldwide annually, but among them, the number of earthquakes causing loss of life and property is not more than ten. At the beginning of the 20th century, American scientist Taylor and German scientist Alfred studied the development of the earth and the present form of the continents. The picture of the earth's development that emerged from the research of these two suggests that once the eastern border of South America and the western border of Africa were one. Similarly, the border of northwest Africa matched the border of North America. Australia today was once part of Antarctica. The area below the Vindhya and Rajmahal ranges in India today was once an island-like region in the middle of the South Pole. Geologists call this piece of land the Gondwana land. Over time, the Gondwana land moved northeast towards Asia. Between Asia and the Gondwana land was the Tethys Sea. But about 53 million years ago, the Gondwana land and the Asian mainland collided. The Tethys Sea first shrunk, but later, constant rain on the Asian mainland and the sand and silt that came with it completely filled this sea. Today's Ganga valley is the filled sea between the Asian mainland and the Gondwana land. There is another aspect to this entire story. Scientists believe that when the Asian and Gondwana lands collided, the Rajmahal range of present-day Chotanagpur-Santhal Pargana and the Garo range of the northeastern states were the first to collide. Due to this combination, the path for water flow eastward was blocked. Now, any water that fell to the south of the Asian land or to the north of the Gondwana land all flowed westwards to the sea. Meaning, at that time, the Ganga actually flowed backwards, while the water of the Brahmaputra valley also flowed into the Arabian Sea. But gradually, the entire Gondwana land joined Asia; its west-north side grew more strongly towards Asia, and the Garo and Rajmahal hills separated from each other again. Thus, most of the water drainage started eastwards, and the Ganga was born, which flows from the Himalayas to the Bay of Bengal. The mountains or rocks on the northern border of the Gondwana land, called the

Rajmahal range and the Vindhya mountain range, were very old, but the Asian land was only new soft soil. When the pressure of the Gondwana land came on this crumbly soil, it turned into mountains, but these mountains are not of stone; they are made of soft soil, which takes lakhs of years to become rock. The mountains of present-day Nepal and Bhutan are still new, and they also have such slopes and valleys. In such a situation, when rain falls on these mountains along with water, the currents emerging from them carry large amounts of soil and sand. For hundreds of years, the soil and sand flowing down from the northern mountains formed the Ganga valley and its plains. Two things are clear from the various plates of the earth. One is that the pressure of the present-day Indian land is northward on the Asian mainland, and the second is that almost the entire northern part of India is a junction zone of the two plates. Due to the friction of the plates, severe earthquakes occur in this region. The displacement of the earth's mass is a very slow process, which cannot be experienced in a hundred or fifty years. Such changes can be experienced in thousands of years. The formation of the Ganga valley was also such an event. Thousands of years of rainfall and the resulting sediment contributed to the formation of this valley.

Water Cycle: Rainfall has its own principle. Due to sunlight, water from the ocean evaporates and rises towards the sky. Once high up, due to low temperature, this vapor cools and takes the form of clouds, moving towards the land due to the effect of wind. This water is stored in the clouds as raindrops, hail, or snow and falls to the ground under favorable conditions, becoming the basis of life for living beings. Dew or fog is another form of this water. Some of the water that falls on the ground flows back to the sea through drains and rivers. Some water returns to the atmosphere through activities like transpiration from plants, and some water goes underground, enriching the groundwater level. In fact, this water current exists underground just as we see rivers on the surface. Underground water also maintains its connection with the sea like surface water. Thus, the water cycle from the ocean to the ocean is completed. This entire process is called the water cycle, in which nature transforms the ocean's salty water into useful fresh water. Life on Earth cannot be imagined without fresh water. This continuous journey of water from ocean to ocean never stops.

River Course Change: In hilly areas, the slope of the land is so steep that water does not stop, but when the river descends from the mountains to the plains, the

slope of the land decreases significantly, causing the speed of the water to reduce considerably. The water of the river flowing down from the mountains carries not just water, but also large amounts of trees, rocks, stones, sand, and soil. When the slope of the land decreases, stones do not travel far. But the soil/sand keeps moving with the river water. Due to the decrease in land slope and water velocity, this soil/sand gets a chance to settle on the riverbed. Additionally, when the river breaks its bank and flows, the sand and soil brought with the water spread over the entire area and accumulate. The river thus builds the land. A decrease in the river's speed is observed where it descends from the mountains to the plains, but where this river meets a larger river during floods, the speed of the smaller river often turns into stagnation, because the water of the smaller river flows according to the water level in the larger river. A similar situation arises at the mouth of a river meeting the sea, due to the rising tide in the sea. Due to the cessation of speed, the accumulation of soil/sand accelerates at these two locations, leading to the formation of new land/delta. A 6.5 km wide strip formed at the mouth of the Mississippi River in the US in a hundred years. The Yangtze-Kiang River in China has formed a 48 km wide delta in historical times. The Shok Hwang Ho River in China has formed a delta about 500 km wide since about 5500 BCE. Similarly, the Ganga river has formed a delta over about 250 km before reaching the sea. In most European countries, it rains almost all year round. In our country, there is a rainy season, and about 87 percent of the total annual rainfall occurs between mid-June and mid-October. After the end of the rains and the flood, some sand/soil gets deposited in that area. Due to the flood, a thick layer of sand/soil accumulates in some places, becomes thin in others, gorges form due to erosion, and water accumulates in some places. In the next season, when the floodwater rises again, the soil deposited from the previous year is cut away, forming a new path. Sometimes this new path becomes so large and effective that the river itself bursts onto this new path. The river water that carries a higher amount of sand/soil will have more deposition of sand/soil in its floodplain, and such a river has a greater chance of change. That is why the rivers joining the right bank of the Ganga have less chance of change compared to those joining the left bank, because the rivers joining the right bank come from the plateau and carry less soil/sand, while those joining the left bank come from the soft, fragile Himalayan mountains, bringing large amounts of soil/sand. The changing course of a river with high sediment load is as natural and normal an event as the movement of the earth's plates, rainfall, and delta formation by rivers. Thus, problems like floods, erosion, waterlogging, and river course changes are more severe in the left (northern) part of the Ganga.

This problem is more severe where the slope of the land is almost flat. Such locations are found in the Ganga valley in eastern Uttar Pradesh, the plains of North Bihar, and North Bengal. But this does not mean that there is complete peace on the right bank of the Ganga regarding floods. In the plains there, the problem is as much as on the northern bank of the Ganga. The issues arising from floods in the Bhojpur, Rohtas, Patna, Munger, Bhagalpur, and Sahebganj districts of Bihar are proof of that. To the south of this valley are the Vindhya and Satpura mountain ranges, which are part of the Gondwana land. These hills are much older than the Himalayan mountains and have become strong rock. Erosion of soil is less in these hills compared to the Shivalik and Himalayas. However, in terms of area, the northern region of the Ganga is more devastated by floods.

Flood and its Historical Context: After understanding the process of formation of the Ganga basin, the journey of water from ocean to ocean, and the reasons for river course changes, one thing becomes clear: there is no hope of stopping the displacement of the earth. Rain will continue to fall, and when this water falls on the soil, erosion will occur, rivers will change their course, and floods will keep coming. Humans, with their intellectual skills, can bring about some change in soil erosion, river course change, and floods. Their capacity is not such as of yet. One thing to note here is that North Bihar, or the entire plain of the Ganga valley, is a fertile region, and its fertility has certainly increased due to the silt brought by the river water during floods. Due to being an agriculturally rich region since ancient times, various civilizations developed here. Nature, however, does not distribute only charity. If there is a rose, there is also a thorn. Wherever there is a rich source of fresh water in the form of rain, where the river network spreads over some distance, floods, erosion, and river course changes are more heard of. A river is a powerful means of spreading silt/sand over a large area and reaching the ocean, which, during floods, reaches the sea from its origin. In fact, such land formation is a natural characteristic of a river. This region of the Ganga valley might have been an area of sea sand and salty water at one time. But due to rain, the soft soil of the Himalayas began to flow down from the north, making the land fertile. The land we are talking about is counted among the most fertile lands in the world, and this river is considered the only source of water resources. Apart from materialistic beliefs, the importance of the river for us is like a life-giving force. The foundation of Indian culture has been rivers. So many civilizations have developed on the banks of these rivers since time immemorial and have dissolved into nature's

womb over time, but our connection with these rivers has always remained pure and like a mother's love for her devotees. Where Maharishi Ved Vyasa expressed his reverence for rivers in the Mahabharata, he calls them 'Visvasya Matarah', meaning mothers of the people. Scholars like Kautilya considered such places unfit for habitation where a beautiful river does not flow continuously. He highlighted the importance of rivers, saying 'Na tatra divasam vaset' – one should not stay even for a day in such a place. In our auspicious rituals, Indians never forget to invoke rivers along with deities and ancestors. No auspicious ritual of ours is complete without remembering the Ganga, Yamuna, Godavari, Saraswati, Narmada, Sindhu, and Kaveri. To give an example of purity, we recall the Narmada, and we take pride in being called children of the Ganga. The desire to 'obtain the Ganga at death' did not arise only in saints like Kabir because he spent most of his life on the banks of the Ganga. The tradition of calling any river the Ganga out of emotion is still alive in our people. The mention of Lord Shri Krishna would remain incomplete without 'Kālindi kūla kadamb kī ḍāran' (the Kadamb branches on the bank of Kalindi). How many times has Valmiki seen Lord Rama paying respects to the Sarayu? Kshipra gave elegance to Kalidasa's writings. The concept of Tirtha (literally meaning the bank of a river) gave expression to the belief in the glory of rivers. We have a distinct tradition of bathing in rivers on such special occasions. Ganga Dussehra, Magh Purnima, Kartik Purnima, Sankranti, etc., there are many such occasions when our ancestors made arrangements to bring people to the riverside. The scriptures had strict directives against discharge etc., to maintain the purity of the river. Bihar's Chhath festival, along with sun worship, is an excellent example of our reverence for the river. A small link in this rich heritage is the Mahananda river, flowing through the eastern districts of North Bihar, Kishanganj, Purnia, and Katihar. In the Mahabharata, there is mention of two rivers, Nanda and Upper Nanda, flowing near the Kaushiki (Kosi) river, where the Pandavas came during their exile. It is believed that the Upper Nanda of the Mahabharata period is the present-day Mahananda. The description of the Mahananda's tributary, Kankai, is also found in the Mahabharata, where it is called Kankananda. Every year, on Magh Purnima day, a fair is held at Durgapur and Kalyan in Katihar district to express reverence for the Mahananda. On this day, a fair is also held on the banks of the Ganga at Kadha Gola in this area.

Mahananda River: The Mahananda is a major river of North Bihar. Its origin is at Chimle in the Himalayas, 6 km north of Karseong in Darjeeling district, West

Bengal, from where it begins its journey of 376 km at an altitude of 2062 meters. After its confluence with the Kankai, the Mahananda crosses the Barhi-Guwahati National Highway 31 near Bagjhora and reaches Bagdob, where its current splits into two parts. The current flowing almost straight south at Bagdob is called the Jhaua branch, and most of the Mahananda's water flow currently passes through this branch. The Jhaua branch itself, as it proceeds further, is joined on its right bank by the Panar river. This branch further crosses the Katihar-Barsoi railway line near Jhaua and the Katihar-Malda railway line near Labha. Another tributary of the Mahananda's Jhaua branch, the Ghasia, joins it below Labha. From here, the Mahananda's Jhaua branch enters West Bengal's Malda district and meets the Ganga river near Surmara. Another branch of the Mahananda at Bagdob, flowing in the south-east direction, crosses the Katihar-Barsoi railway line near Barsoi. Below Barsoi, this current also splits into two parts. Among these, the current flowing east is more active, while the one flowing west has become inactive and has accumulated sand/silt. This current rejoins the main current near Subarnapur. Now this combined current meets the Ganga at Godagiri Ghat in Bangladesh. The total catchment area of the Mahananda is 24,753 square kilometers, of which 5293 square km is in Nepal, 6677 square km in West Bengal, 7957 square km in Bihar, and the rest in Bangladesh. North of Dangra Ghat, the slope of this river's bed is relatively high, which gradually decreases below Dangra Ghat, causing the river's flow capacity to gradually decrease, and the river often overflows its banks. In the lower part, the bed slope of the Jhaua branch is 0.099 meters per kilometer, while that of the Barsoi branch is 0.146 meters per kilometer. According to government reports of the 1960s and earlier, as a result of this lack of slope, there used to be water accumulation for about a week in the lower part of the Mahananda, resulting in the destruction of the then southern part of Purnia (newly formed Katihar). According to these reports, the Mahananda was not the only cause of this destruction in Katihar; the Kari Kosi and Ganga rivers also contributed significantly.

A characteristic of the Mahananda's tributaries is that they keep changing their course, and their names also change accordingly. For example, the Panar river has many names like Panar, Parman, Parmaun, Kadwa, Riga, Kankar, Fulhar, or Gangajuri. As the place changes, the river's name also changes. Similarly, the Bakra river's name changes to Bakra, Katua River, or Devani at different places. Many new and old currents of the Kankai are scattered in its catchment area. The situation of the Mechi, Dauk, Ramzan, Kulik, Sudhani, and Nagar

rivers is also similar. The currents of these rivers keep splitting, the amount of water flowing in them keeps changing, and their importance keeps increasing or decreasing accordingly. The first survey of this region was conducted in 1779 after the establishment of British rule by a military engineer named James Rennell. The official description of the Mahananda's flow path at that time is found in Rennell's map. Later, Dr. Francis Buchanan Hamilton (1809-10), Robert Montgomery Martin (1838), and Dr. W.W. Hunter (1877) also gave sequential descriptions of this river.

It is said about the Mahananda that it is not only the last eastern outpost of Aryan influence, but the history of this region also involves the struggle between invaders coming from the west and the indigenous people. According to the Imperial Gazetteer of India, 'the Mahananda serves as a boundary between the Hindi-speaking region of the west and the Bengali-speaking region of the east.' According to population figures, the Hindi-speaking population is 94.6 percent, while only 5 percent are Bengali-speaking. However, Dr. Grierson's estimate was that about one-third of the people would be Bengali speakers, and this seems correct. The Mahananda also acts as a border line. In Purnia district, two-thirds of the population in the east was Muslim, while in the west it was less than one-third.

But without the Kosi, the description of the Mahananda remains incomplete. The Kosi is a very important river of Nepal and Bihar, originating from the main Himalayan range at an altitude of 5400 meters. After traveling about 725 km through Tibet, Nepal, and North Bihar, it merges with the Ganga near Kursela (Katihar). The length of this river in Bihar is 254 km, while its total length in the plains is 307 km. The Kosi river, formed by the confluence of three streams, Surya Kosi, Tama Kosi, and Arun Kosi, has a total catchment area of 58,594 square km, of which 5,704 square km is glacier. Apart from mythological texts, legends, folklore, and folk songs, written information about the Kosi was prepared by the British. Their travelogues and survey reports extensively discussed these rivers, though their main objective was to exploit the natural resources of the region and collect revenue. The travelogues of Francis Buchanan (1909-10) and Robert Montgomery Martin (1838) and Hunter's "Statistical Accounts of Bengal" (1877) contain much written about this river. These records show that the Kosi has long been notorious for changing its channel, the reason being its high sediment load. Based on available records between 1736 and 1955, it is estimated that during this period,

this river used to flow east of Purnia, but now it has shifted about 110 km west and flows through Supaul, Madhubani, Saharsa, Khagaria districts and meets the Ganga. Local people say that the Kosi once used to flow through Malda (West Bengal), and according to Buchanan Hamilton, this river may have even flowed east of Malda. Buchanan writes: "Local scholars or pandits living on the banks of the Kosi go so far as to say that in ancient times, the Kosi flowed in the south-east direction up to Tajpur. After which it flowed east and ultimately merged with the Brahmaputra, having no connection with the Ganga. I do not understand what is the basis of this statement, folklore or legend. If it is a legend, it becomes somewhat more believable, but it seems quite possible. It is possible that the large lakes located east and north of Malda were once remnants of the Kosi and Mahananda. ... In the above-mentioned change, at least within the company's territory, no river joins the Kosi on its left bank, but several currents are born from it. Many rivers coming from the northern mountains now join the Mahananda, and it is quite possible that these rivers previously joined the Kosi when its current was in the north-east direction...".

Hunter (1877), however, disagreed with Buchanan's view and said, "Dr. Buchanan Hamilton's suggestion that the Kosi might have merged with the Brahmaputra seems less plausible compared to his other theories. It seems that previously the Brahmaputra's course was east of Mymensingh. On its eastward course, the Kosi would have previously met the Karatua, which is itself a river, fed by the Atrai and Teesta. In my Account of District Bogra (Vol. VIII p. 139, 142, 162), I have highlighted its importance based on the size and significance of this river since the beginning of the Hindu era and have said that this river clearly acts as a boundary line for the human race, which is still observable. If it is accepted that the Kosi and Mahananda used to meet at Karatua in the past, then the large size of the Karatua in ancient times can be understood, and then the reason for the sandy plain between the Barind forest of Rajshahi district and Madhupur of Mymensingh can also be understood. The argument about where the Brahmaputra flowed at the beginning of this century would also become clear. In fact, there is not an inch of land between Purnia and Darbhanga where the Kosi's current has never flowed. Its various currents have many names – Saura, Barandi, Kari Kosi, Mara Kosi, Tilave River, Haiyadhar, Bochaha River, Majhari River, Dhemura River, Mirchaiya River, Laguniya River, etc. etc. Whatever current the Kosi's main stream flowed in became the Kosi. Thus, the area between the Kosi and Mahananda has always been an area of floods and erosion, for which the Kosi is largely credited. But as far as the issue of floods is

concerned, the noise of the Mahananda is sometimes heard in the noise of the Kosi."

Dense forests, inaccessible roads, and the presence of a river at a short distance – perhaps these reasons led the Pandavas to choose this region for their exile, which holds a very important place in mythology. It is said that during the Mahabharata period, this region was under Karna. Kursela, where the Kosi meets the Ganga, fell in the Kaurava kingdom and was then known as Kurushila. At one time, Manihari (Katihar) was originally named Maniharan, where Lord Shri Krishna's ring stone was lost. The Simil forest, where Arjuna hid his weapons during his incognito stay, is present-day Semapur, a railway station on the Katihar-Barauni road. Similarly, there is a legend about Thakurganj town in Kishanganj district that it was part of King Virata's kingdom, and Bhima spent his exile here as a cook (Bhanasiya/Thakur). There are two ponds in this locality named Bhatdhala and Sagdhala, where Bhima used to store rice and greens. Not far from Thakurganj is the place where Bhima killed Keechaka. Compared to leaving this district, the tradition of going outside is notable. People of Purnia avoid working hard in the fields and do not like leaving the district in search of livelihood. Considering the area, the population is low, land is easily available, and labor is less. These are some of the reasons that prevent people from Purnia from going out. Many people come from outside temporarily during the farming season. This was said in 1963. Accidents happen while sitting on train roofs, causing deaths, and such incidents have claimed lives of people from the Kosi-Mahananda doab. Deaths have also occurred due to building collapses and attacks by crocodiles. Between 1963 and 1993, something definitely changed: the people of Purnia, who used to avoid laboring in fields, and those who never liked leaving the district in search of livelihood, were forced to go outside and work in others' fields, paying a price. Whereas earlier, during harvest time and when laborers were needed in Assam's tea gardens, trains from Katihar and beyond used to be crowded with laborers from different parts of Uttar Pradesh and Bihar. In fact, if such laborers did not go to Purnia during harvest, the harvest, especially jute, would be almost impossible. This journey from prosperity to misery occurred in the last thirty years. Over the past four decades, the impact of development is becoming clearly visible in this way. How did this Kosi-Mahananda doab suddenly become surplus in terms of labor? One reason is that due to floods in this region, large areas remain submerged for long periods, making farming impossible. However, flood is not the only reason for this, because if there is

flood in North Bihar today, there is drought in South Bihar, but the people there are suffering almost similar adverse effects of development as the people of North Bihar. There is no flood there, yet why is this happening? There too, children do not go to school, people are migrating in search of wages. But it is also hard for us to accept that all this is due to population growth. Agriculture is a sector with maximum employment potential. So, if farming can be improved somehow, many people would get connected to the land, and the crowds on train roofs would reduce significantly. Not the Mahananda, but discussion on the Kosi's floods has been ongoing since the latter half of the last century. In other parts of India, the Kosi is cited as an example of a flood-bringing river, and this river remains at the center of any flood discussion. After independence, attempts were made to control this river, and along with it, attempts were made to control rivers across almost the entire Ganga and Brahmaputra valley, and in this sequence, the Mahananda also came into focus.

The geographical situation of North Bihar is such that this region is the "playground" for many large rivers (such as – Kosi, Gandak, Bagmati, Mahananda). Approximately 16% of India's total flood-affected area lies solely in Bihar.

Embankments: Protector or Devourer? The government built 'embankments' (earthen walls) on the banks of rivers to stop floods. But this solution has become more of a problem than a solution: Waterlogging: Due to the embankment, rainwater from outside cannot flow into the river, causing fields to remain submerged for months. Breach of Embankment: When the Kosi embankment (Kushaha) broke on August 18, 2008, it caused severe devastation. When it breaks, the velocity of water becomes many times higher than normal. Rising River Bed: Within the embankments, the river deposits its sediment, causing the river's surface to rise.

Mahananda – The Story: The author describes the geographical form of the Mahananda river, its origin, and its historical significance in the Mithila/Seemanchal region.

River Origin and Flow: The Mahananda river originates from the Darjeeling Himalayas at an altitude of about 2100 meters. This river flows through

Darjeeling (West Bengal) and the Kishanganj, Purnia, and Katihar districts of Bihar, ultimately merging with the Ganga river.

Network of Tributaries: The Mahananda's special feature is its tributaries. Among these, the Mechi, Kanakai, Nagar, Tangan, and Punarbhaba are prominent. These rivers bring huge amounts of water and 'silt' from Nepal and Sikkim, making the Mahananda floods more severe.

The 'Imprisoned' Form of the River: The river was made 'imprisoned' by building embankments. The Mahananda is fickle by nature and has always been changing its course, but modern engineering attempted to confine it to a fixed path.

Impact on Agriculture and Culture: The life and culture of the people in the Mahananda region are completely dependent on this river. Where this river brought fertile soil, the problem of 'waterlogging' has increased since the construction of embankments. According to the author, the Mahananda is not just a water stream, but the economic backbone of that region.

Beginning of Administrative Neglect: Compared to the Kosi and Bagmati, the administration always 'ignored' the floods in the Mahananda region, even though the devastation there was no less.

Traditional Flood Management Methods: People of the Mahananda region were accustomed to living with floods earlier. They built their houses on high platforms and used the fertile soil brought by the floodwater for farming.

The Idea of Embankments and the British Era: The British rulers thought of building embankments to protect their trade and administrative facilities (railways and roads). However, seeing the geographical situation and network of tributaries of the Mahananda, even British engineers were initially afraid to build embankments. Citing the 1897 'Calcutta Conference', the author says that greater emphasis was placed on drainage rather than embankments at that time.

Influence of the Kosi 'Model': After independence, when work on embankments on the Kosi river began, its influence also fell on the Mahananda. Due to political pressure and in the name of 'quick relief', the demand to build embankments on the Mahananda also intensified.

Mahananda Embankment Scheme (1960s-70s): A blueprint for the Mahananda Embankment Scheme was prepared in the late 1960s and early 1970s. Its goal was to embank the river from Kishanganj to Malda (West Bengal).

Technical Dilemma: There were disagreements among engineers about how successful it would be to confine such a fickle river, which constantly changes its course, within embankments.

Administrative and Political Decision: According to the author, the decision to build embankments on the Mahananda was more 'political' than technical. The government tried to show the people that it was taking a big step for flood protection, while the long-term consequences (such as silt accumulation) were ignored.

Project Conception: The Mahananda project was finalized in the late 1960s. Its main objective was to protect 722,000 acres of land in Purnia, Katihar, and Malda districts from floods. The plan aimed to build embankments on both banks of the river and connect several tributaries to the main stream.

Problem of Tributaries: The biggest challenge for the Mahananda is its tributaries (such as Mechi, Kanakai, Bakra). These rivers are so fickle that they can render the embankments useless by changing their course at any time.

Neglect of Drainage: After the embankments were built, smaller rivers and rainwater from surrounding areas were prevented from merging into the Mahananda. The result was that 'waterlogging' became a permanent problem in the area outside the embankments. Thousands of acres of fertile land turned into swamps, worsening the farmers' economic condition.

Displacement and Rehabilitation: Like the Kosi and Bagmati, the condition of villages trapped between the embankments on the Mahananda became hellish. The government's rehabilitation policy remained limited to paper. People were evicted from their ancestral lands, and they were not even provided basic facilities in the new locations.

Technical Flaws and Corruption: According to the author, political interests were prioritized over local geography when deciding the alignment of the embankments. Due to corruption in construction work, the strength of the embankments was always questionable, leading to the spending of crores of rupees annually on maintenance.

Instability of Embankments: According to the author, the river was confined by building embankments, but this did not provide permanent security. The Mahananda and its tributaries are so fierce that they can breach the embankments anytime and anywhere.

Major Breach Events: Several major breaches in the 1970s and 80s are mentioned. When an embankment breaks, the water enters villages with such force that people get no time to react.

The Catastrophic Flood of 1987: That year, severe devastation occurred in the Mahananda region. The embankment broke at many places, and large parts of Katihar-Purnia were submerged.

The 'Rat and Jackal' Argument: Like the Kosi and Bagmati, when the Mahananda embankment broke, government officials would blame it on 'rat holes' or 'jackal burrows'. The author strongly criticizes this argument, considering it a pretext to hide administrative negligence.

Corruption in Maintenance: Crores of rupees are spent every year on the name of embankment maintenance. This work is often done hastily just before the floods, using substandard materials. This corruption is a major reason for breaches.

Impact on People's Lives: When an embankment breaks, not only houses are destroyed, but fields are filled with sand. Farmers lose their capital and have to wait for government 'assistance'.

Age of Embankments and Illusion of Safety: According to the author, embankments have a fixed lifespan. Considering the rate at which 'silt' is accumulating in the Mahananda, there is a limit to increasing the height of the embankments. Now these walls are becoming more a cause of danger than safety, because the river bed has become higher than the surrounding villages.

Priority for Drainage: More attention should be paid to 'drainage' than 'flood control'. More bridges and 'sluice gates' are needed to drain the water that gets trapped due to the embankments. It is imperative to rejuvenate natural drains and old streams so that rainwater can drain easily.

Participation of Local Society: No input is taken from local people in the government's large-scale schemes. The author believes that as long as 'traditional knowledge' is not incorporated into engineering, no scheme will be successful.

Change in Farming Pattern: Farmers in the Mahananda region will have to learn the art of 'living with floods'. They will have to choose crops that can survive in water or can be harvested before/after the flood.

Need for Administrative Honesty: It is very important to stop the corruption happening in the name of maintenance and relief. Unless transparency is brought in at the technical and administrative levels, the Mahananda will remain 'imprisoned' and the people of the region will remain 'sufferers'.

Definition of 'Benefit' and Reality: The government claimed that farmers were benefiting from the embankment, but according to the author, the biggest beneficiaries were engineers, contractors, and politicians. The Mahananda embankment became a 'source of income', where crores of rupees are spent every year on the name of maintenance and construction.

Loss to Farmers: Due to the embankments, thousands of farmers lost their fertile land. Those whose land fell 'inside' (the river side) faced uncertain farming, and those whose land fell 'outside' faced crop destruction due to 'waterlogging'.

Social Inequality: The embankment divided society into two parts – one supposedly protected by the embankment, and the other drowning because of it. This also affected the harmony within villages.

Government Machinery and Insensitivity: The chapter shows how in government schemes, 'statistics' are given more importance than 'human sensitivity'. Even the distribution of relief materials has become a game of corruption.

The Mahananda river originates from the Mahaladhiram hills of the Himalayas and flows through the Kishanganj, Purnia, and Katihar districts of Bihar to West Bengal and Bangladesh. Through this book, Dinesh Kumar Mishra, himself a sharp water expert and engineer, attempts to show how an independent and fickle river was confined in the name of 'development' and how its 'imprisoned' form became a destructive factor. The book's title 'Bandini' is not just a word, but a symbol of the fate of millions of people who got trapped within the embankments.

The author begins the book with the history of the Mahananda. The Mahananda is known for changing its course. Earlier, this river was a boon for the people. Its flood used to bring 'silt' (fertility) with it, making jute and paddy cultivation flourish. The author notes that earlier people knew how to 'live with floods' rather than 'fight floods'.

In the 1960s, the plan to build embankments on the Mahananda was conceived. The government's argument was that building embankments would free the region from floods and increase agricultural production. In the book, the author analyzes in detail the government files where this scheme was prepared. He shows how the opinions of local people were disregarded, and emphasis was placed solely on concrete and earthen structures.

A large part of the book is focused on the devastating flood of 1987. Using statistical data and eyewitness accounts, the author proves that after the embankments were built, floods did not decrease, but their intensity and destructive power increased. Due to the embankments, sedimentation occurred in the river bed, causing the river level to rise. When the embankment broke, the water came in with such force that it caused immense loss of life and property.

A major consequence of the embankment is 'waterlogging'. The water outside the embankment cannot enter the river, causing fields to remain submerged for months. The author calls this 'permanent flood'. Its consequences: diseases like malaria and kala-azar spread; people's migration increased; land prices fell; and people got trapped in debt.

Dinesh Kumar Mishra's biggest criticism is of the modern engineering thought that views a river as a 'pipe'. He writes that a river is not just water, but a living system of water, soil, and vegetation. By building embankments, we block its natural drainage. The author argues that the Mahananda's geography is hilly, where water comes down swiftly; in such a case, an embankment is insufficient to stop it.

The author fearlessly exposes the 'flood economy'. According to him: Contractor system: Building and repairing embankments is a 'cash cow' for contractors, engineers, and politicians. Politics of Relief: When a flood comes, a large part of the relief distributed is lost to corruption. Mishra ji says that if floods were to end, many people's shops would close, so the system wants to keep floods 'permanent'.

The author's biggest sorrow is that the experience of the rural people who live with the river was dismissed as uneducated and rejected. In the book, he includes interviews with several such farmers who could make more accurate predictions than government engineers. In the author's view, this is 'intellectual colonialism'.

In 'Bandini Mahananda', the depiction of the pain of displaced people is very poignant. For the people who got trapped between the embankments, there are no paved roads, no schools. They are forced to live in 'no man's land'. The

author questions whether this is not a 'violation of human rights' done in the name of 'development'.

Mishra ji does not just list problems; he also shows the path to solutions: Review of Embankments: Where embankments have become destructive, they should be removed or 'sluice gates' should be installed in them. Restoration of Natural Drainage: The old paths of the river and wetlands should be rejuvenated so that floodwater can spread and calm down. Decentralized Water Management: Instead of large dams, attention should be paid to local ponds and ahar-pyne systems.

A detailed discussion of the history of the Mahananda project, its implementation, and its long-term consequences is presented. According to the author, the decision to build embankments on the Mahananda was more a result of political pressure and compulsion than scientific research. Until independence, the Mahananda's floods were not a particular cause for concern. However, after the West Bengal government constructed the 'Malior Dam' in its area, the devastation of floods increased in Bihar's region. Compelled by this and enthused by the 'so-called' success of the Kosi project, the Bihar government started work on building embankments on the Mahananda in 1972.

Initially, this scheme was estimated to cost only Rs. 1.22 crore, but by 1993, more than Rs. 52.47 crore had been spent on it. The length of the embankment also increased from 208 km to 336 km. This included embankments on the Kari Kosi, Barandi, and Ganga along with the Mahananda.

Contrary to government claims, after the embankments were built, the intensity of floods increased instead of decreasing. According to the author, this was a project based on "thinking without considering profit or loss." Due to the embankments, rainwater gets trapped in the middle, and there is no arrangement for drainage. From 1975 to 1991, the embankment broke many times, causing huge loss of life and property.

For the rehabilitation of the people trapped between the embankments, the government conducted a survey based on the "Unitary method," which was completely flawed. People's homes were destroyed, but they did not receive

adequate compensation or new land. People of villages like Siktiya and Solkandha are still forced to live a hellish life.

Engineers ignored the river's nature and the process of siltation. Due to silt accumulation, the riverbed is rising, making the embankment's safety always at risk. The author calls this factor a technical "deception." He argues that to get the project approved, the benefits were shown to be more and the costs less, deliberately. The reality is that after the project, both the area affected by floods and the population affected increased.

The book shows how leaders and engineers conspired to mislead the public. The author terms the crores of rupees spent annually on 'repair' and 'relief' in the name of flood control as the 'fourth crop', which is riddled with corruption. Due to the embankments, traditional farming (paddy-jute) has been destroyed. People are getting trapped in the clutches of moneylenders and are forced to migrate (to Delhi, Punjab, Assam) for employment. The author poignantly depicts the poverty and helplessness of the people through the example of 'Cursed Siktiya'.

Dinesh Mishra's book presents the Mahananda project as a 'death-trap'. The core point of his criticism is that instead of fighting nature, it is more important to coexist with it, which was not done in this project.

'Bandini Mahananda' is not just a technical book; it is a 'dirge' for the geography of Mithila and Seemanchal. This work by Dinesh Kumar Mishra warns us that if we still do not learn to love nature, then the 'Sadgati' (final liberation/good ending) of many rivers like the Mahananda will become horrific.

The subject matter of this book is connected to the fundamental problem of the Mithila region. Although this book is originally in Hindi, its soul is Maithili. This book inspires us to fight for our land, water, and the rights of our people.

'Bandini Mahananda' bares that development model which is built at the cost of the lives of the poor. It is essential for anyone who wants to understand the real reasons for floods, poverty, and displacement in North Bihar.

The rivers of North Bihar were not just geographical water streams; they were the foundation of the region's social structure, economic destiny, and literary consciousness. In this context, Dr. Dinesh Kumar Mishra's work, especially his book 'Bandini Mahananda', is a work of a transitional period that builds a bridge between the technical rigidity of engineering and the fluidity of folk history. Published in 1994 by Samata Prakashan, Patna, this book was a documentation of the ecological and human crisis of the Mahananda river, which not only questioned water management policies but also gave birth to an unprecedented controversy in Maithili literature and intellectual discourse. Although Dinesh Kumar Mishra is not a native of Mithila, by writing the 'historical biography' of Mithila's rivers – Kosi, Kamla, Bagmati, and Mahananda – the scholars of the 'Parallel Stream' in Maithili accept the debt he owes to this region with immense gratitude.

From 'Bandini Mahananda' to Liberation

Dinesh Kumar Mishra's 'Bandini Mahananda' was not just an account of a river, but a narrative of the failure of that modern model of development in which nature was viewed as an object. His research made it clear that until we revive our traditional art of 'living with rivers', Bihar's rivers will remain 'imprisoned' and their riparian communities will remain trapped in poverty.

The controversy woven around his work in Maithili literature shows that truth and research often become uncomfortable for power structures. 'Bandini Mahananda' was a powerful attempt to break the silence, which will continue to inspire future generations to adopt a sensitive and scientific approach towards rivers.

Bagavat Par Majboor Mithila Ki Kamla Nadi (2004)

Dinesh Kumar Mishra's Book The Kamla River and People On Collision Course

Chapter 1: Kamla – The Identity of a River

The book provides a mythological, geographical, and cultural introduction to the Kamla river and discusses its unique contribution to Mithila's agriculture.

Mithila's 'Gold'-Producing River: The Kamla river is considered a highly beneficial river for the Mithila region. Compared to the Kosi, the Kamla brings such nutrients that are a boon for farming. There is a local belief that the land of the Kamla basin produces 'gold'. If the river water reaches the fields at the right time, up to 80 kg of paddy can be easily produced per katta of land.

Geographical Course and Origin: The Kamla river originates from the 'Mahabharat' mountain range in Nepal and enters India at Jaynagar in Madhubani district, Bihar, coming from Dhanusha district (Nepal). In Mithila, this river mainly flows through Madhubani and Darbhanga districts and ultimately merges into the Kosi river's current.

Mythological and Cultural Neglect: Surprisingly, despite being such a life-giving river, the Kamla does not find mention as often in mythological texts as the Kosi or Ganga. However, in local faith, the Kamla is worshipped as 'Maiya' (Mother). 'Kamla Puja' is an integral part of Mithila's folk culture.

Tributaries and Influence of 'Dhouri': The Kamla incorporates many small hill rivers (like Soni, Balan, Dhouri) along its course. The confluence with the 'Dhouri' river makes the Kamla more fickle and destructive, especially during the rainy season.

River Shifting: The Kamla is known for changing its course. From the 18th century to the present, this river has changed its main channel many times. When the river changes its course, the old path becomes 'almost dead', and the new area brings both devastation and fertility with it.

Traditional Irrigation System: The people of the Kamla region have always been skilled at bringing water to fields through 'pyne' and 'ahar' systems. Temporary bamboo and earthen 'checks' were made to stop water. This system

was completely based on community cooperation, with all villagers participating in voluntary labor.

Conception of the Jaynagar Barrage: A plan was made at the government level to build a barrage at Jaynagar (Madhubani) to manage the Kamla's water. Its main objective was to channel the water through a fixed canal to the fields. However, according to the author, the barrage disrupted the river's natural flow and the path of the fertile 'silt' (nutrients) it brought.

Canal and Drainage: The chapter highlights the failure of the canal system. Although the canal was built, due to lack of cleaning and maintenance, water did not reach the farmers at the tail end. Its reverse effect was that the high embankments of the canal hindered the 'natural drainage' of the area, causing the problem of 'waterlogging'.

Political and Administrative Interference: The author says that in irrigation schemes, 'contractorism' and 'engineering hubris' dominated over the needs of local farmers. Water distribution became a political issue, benefiting those with access while poor farmers were deprived.

Conception of Embankments (1950s): After the construction of embankments on the Kosi river, the demand for embankments for flood protection also intensified in the Kamla region. After the severe flood of 1954-55, the government decided to build earthen high walls (embankments) on both banks of the Kamla river. In the first phase, embankments were built from Jaynagar to Jhajharpur so that water would flow straight along the river course instead of spreading into villages.

Tragedy Inside the Embankments: Several villages got trapped between the two walls after the embankments were built. For these people, 'flood' became a permanent tragedy. When water comes into the river, these villagers leave their homes and take shelter on the high embankments. Their crops and livestock are always at stake.

Obstruction of Drainage: The biggest technical failure is pointed out to be 'drainage'. The rainwater from the Kamla's tributaries and rainfall, which previously easily merged into the main stream, had their paths blocked by the embankments. As a result, even the area 'outside' the embankments faced 'artificial floods' and waterlogging problems that lasted for weeks.

Breach and Maintenance of Embankments: According to the author, an embankment is not a permanent solution. The Kamla, due to its fickleness, often breaches the embankments. When it breaks, water gushes out with such force that it devastates the surrounding villages. Crores of rupees are spent on maintenance every year, but there is never a guarantee of safety.

Social Conflict: The embankments created a new social conflict between the people 'inside' and 'outside'. Those inside want to cut the embankment for their safety, while those outside guard it to protect themselves.

Kamla – Flowing Towards Damnation: The experiment with embankments on the Kamla proved to be an 'incomplete and flawed' solution. Instead of stopping floods, it turned them into a 'permanent crisis'. According to the author, depriving the river of its rights is the root of this problem.

Cross-Border Issues and Rights to Water: The Kamla river flows from Nepal to India, leading to constant tension between people of the border villages of the two countries over water rights. Nepali farmers want to store water for their irrigation, which directly affects the farming of farmers in Madhubani district, Bihar.

The Jaynagar Barrage and its Failure: The functionality of the barrage built at Jaynagar is questioned. According to the author, this barrage was neither capable of stopping floods nor could it provide sufficient water for irrigation. Silt filling up the barrage gates makes its operation difficult, causing water to change course and enter villages.

Politics of Flood: The author says that flood has become a 'political tool' in the Kamla region. Leaders become active distributing relief during floods, but no

concrete policy for permanent drainage solutions is made. Political parties use the 'anti-embankment movement' for their convenience, but the farmers' problems remain the same.

Neglect of the People in Government Plans: Large files on irrigation and flood control are made in Patna and Delhi, but the 'traditional knowledge' of the people living on the banks of the Kamla finds no place in them. The problems of the Kamla river are not just 'natural' but 'administrative and political'. The tug-of-war over water and ill-considered technical experiments have made the 'path of struggle' for the farmers of the Kamla region even harder.

Kamla – From Insurgency to Surrender: This chapter contains the author's final analysis and suggestions.

Acknowledgment of Embankment Failure: According to the author, the last 50 years of experience show that the embankments built on the Kamla have completely failed in 'flood control'. Due to the embankments, the river bed has risen, keeping the risk of breach constant. Now these structures have become a symbol of 'danger' instead of safety.

From 'Flood' to 'Waterlogging': The chapter highlights that the Kamla's problem is no longer just 'flood', but 'waterlogging'. Due to the embankments, rainwater has no way to drain, rendering lakhs of acres of land unfit for farming.

Local and Traditional Solutions: The author advocates for local solutions instead of 'large barrages' or 'large embankments'. It is necessary to rejuvenate 'pyne' and 'ahar' so that river water can naturally flow to fields and the silt increases fertility.

River Rights and People's Participation: 'Sadgati' (liberation) is only possible when we do not obstruct the natural flow of the river. The opinions and 'traditional knowledge' of local farmers must be included in any new scheme.

Rehabilitation and Justice: Mere 'relief' is not a solution for the people trapped inside the embankments. Their safe rehabilitation and permanent livelihood arrangements should be the government's priority. Freeing the Kamla from its 'bondage' is in Mithila's interest. Living with the river is the only safe path for the future.

Introduction to the Kamla River and Public Faith: The Kamla river is considered a highly fertile and sacred river in the Mithila region. Compared to the Kosi, its water contains more nutrients, making farming yield like 'gold'. In folk tales, the Kamla is considered a 'celibate maiden' and is worshipped by the fisherman (Mallah) community.

Geographical Fickleness: The Kamla is known for changing its course. History mentions its four main paths – 'Bachharaja', 'Patghat', 'Sakri', and 'Jibachh' Kamla. Currently, it flows as 'Kamla-Balan'.

Construction of Embankments (Flood Protection Scheme): After the 1954 flood policy was formulated in independent India, work on building embankments on both banks of the Kamla river began in 1956. These embankments were built from Jaynagar via Jhajharpur to Kothram.

History of Irrigation: The book mentions R.S. King, who developed a successful, low-cost irrigation system in the late 19th century with the help of local pyne and ahar systems. However, modern irrigation schemes (like the Jaynagar Weir and Western Kosi Canal) have proven to be expensive and less effective.

Failure of Engineering: The author argues that embankments trap the river's silt, causing the riverbed to rise. When the water level inside the embankments becomes higher than the land outside, the embankment's breach becomes inevitable, causing devastating floods.

Man-Made Tragedy: The book lists 102 villages that got 'imprisoned' between the embankments. For these 430,000 people, flood is not a disaster but a permanent hell. Their rehabilitation happened only on paper.

Waterlogging: Due to the embankments, rainwater from outside cannot flow into the river, causing waterlogging for months even in 'protected' areas. South of Jhajharpur, this problem is so severe that people cannot cultivate their land.

Political and Technical Interests: The author views the embankment as a 'trap' that has become a source of income for contractors, engineers, and politicians. Meanwhile, traditional knowledge like 'living with floods' was given no place in modern development.

Nepal-India Relations: The book describes the 'Chisapani Dam' as a mirage. According to the author, as long as the sediment management of the Kamla river is not addressed, no dam or embankment can be successful.

Dinesh Kumar Mishra's book makes it clear that the attempt to 'imprison' the Kamla river has become a curse for Mithila. We need to respect the river's natural course and involve the local community in the decision-making process.

The Kamla river, flowing at the center of Mithila's cultural and geographical consciousness, is not just a water stream; it is also the economic base and regulator of the region's social structure. Dinesh Kumar Mishra's timeless research work "The Kamla River and People On Collision Course" presents a detailed document of this river's historical flow, the intervention of modern engineering, and the resulting severe anomalies. This report, based on Dinesh Kumar Mishra's over three decades of research, field visits, and technical analysis, discusses the current crisis of the Kamla river and future challenges.

Originating from Nepal's Mahabharat range and crossing the Himalayan foothills, when the Kamla river enters Bihar at Jaynagar in Madhubani district, its nature is like that of a fickle maiden, leading locals to call it an 'unmarried' or 'virgin' river. The scientific reason for this fickleness is its steep gradient and high silt-carrying capacity.

Statistical Details of Catchment Area and Flow: The total length of the Kamla river and the distribution of its catchment area are divided between Nepal and India, detailed in the table below:

| Geographical Parameter | Description / Statistics |
| : | : |
| Source of River | Churia Range, Sindhuli Gadhi (Nepal) |
| Total Length | 328 kilometers |
| Flow Length in Nepal | 208 kilometers |
| Flow Length in India (Bihar) | 120 kilometers |
| Total Catchment Area | 7,232 square kilometers |
| Catchment Area in Bihar | 4,488 square kilometers |
| Catchment Area in Nepal | 2,744 square kilometers |
| Average Annual Rainfall | 1,260 millimeters |
| Main Tributaries | Soni, Balan, Trishula, Mainavati, Dhouri |

The biggest characteristic of the river's nature is its course change. According to historical evidence, before 1954, the main stream of the Kamla river was 'Bachharaja', but after a severe flood, it changed its course and merged with the Balan river, now jointly called 'Kamla-Balan'.

Under the flood control policy approved by the Government of India in 1954, Kamla-Balan was confined within embankments. The main objective was to keep the river's water flowing in a fixed course to protect the surrounding agricultural land from floods. However, Dinesh Kumar Mishra's analysis proves that this policy was completely contrary to the hydrological character of the Kamla river.

Sediment Deposition and Upward Level of Riverbed: The Kamla is a river carrying excessive silt. Due to the embankments, instead of spreading over the surrounding plains, the silt began accumulating in the river's narrow path. As a result, the riverbed rose above the surrounding land. Data proves that despite less water, the flood level is rising because the river's cross-sectional area has

decreased due to silt. This situation challenges the equation where a decrease in area increases both velocity and level, raising the risk of embankment breach.

Economic Impact: The construction of the embankment has crippled the rural economy of Mithila. Mishra ji describes in detail how people's livelihoods were tampered with in the name of flood control.

Destruction of Agriculture and Traditional Irrigation Systems: Before the embankments, farmers of Mithila used to take three crops a year through 'ahar-pyne' and 'chaur' systems. Floodwater used to bring fertile silt (natural fertilizer) with it. After the embankment construction:

• Destruction of Paddy Crop: The crops of people living inside the embankments drown in floods every year.

• Lack of Irrigation: People living outside the embankments have been deprived of water from old sotis (paleochannels), as their connection to the main river has been cut off.

• Decline in Animal Husbandry: Buffalo rearing has become difficult due to the drying up of chaurs and ponds. Farmers in Madhubani and Darbhanga are now abandoning animal husbandry and are forced to migrate.

Migration and Social Displacement: The approximately 1 million people living inside the embankments can be called "flood refugees". They have neither permanent housing nor safety guarantees. When an embankment breaches, flash floods cause immense loss of life and property. Due to this uncertainty, Mithila's talent and labor force are migrating to Delhi, Punjab, and Gujarat.

The use of the word "Bagavat" (rebellion) in the book's title is multi-dimensional. According to Dinesh Kumar Mishra, this rebellion is not just the river's tendency to break its embankments, but it is a combined resistance of nature and humanity against a failed policy.

River's Rebellion: When a river is prevented from its natural spread, it breaches embankments and seeks its old paths (paleochannels). This is a hydrological compulsion.

People's Rebellion: When water rises inside the embankments and the administration provides no help, people are forced to cut the embankment themselves to save their lives. The administration calls it "the act of anti-social elements," but Mishra ji considers it a final attempt at survival.

Policy Rebellion: This book rebels against the tenets of modern civil engineering that believe a river can be "tamed".

Mishra ji presents a constructive solution in his research. He says the Kamla river has five major old courses – Jivach Kamla, Sakri Kamla, Patghat Kamla, Bachharaja stream, and the current Kamla-Balan – with a total length of about 800 kilometers.

If the government, instead of spending crores on increasing embankment heights, reconnected these old courses to the main river, the flood crisis could end automatically. These courses would absorb the excess floodwater and also serve as irrigation sources for the rabi crop. This is not 'connecting rivers' but 'reconnecting the river with its family'.

Inequality of Disaster Impact: Floods impact the Musahar, Mallah, and landless laborer classes the most. The people trapped inside the embankments also face caste-based discrimination. Even in flood relief camps, these communities are neglected in resource distribution.

According to Dinesh Kumar Mishra, the contractor system that developed in the name of flood control benefited only politicians and engineers, while the condition of the poor people worsened year after year. Now, to deal with the crisis, talk of "Green Belt" and "Community Based Adaptation" is happening, but as long as the fundamental failure of the embankments is not accepted, no permanent solution is possible.

Conclusion: Sadgati (Liberation) or Damnation? "The Kamla River and People On Collision Course" is not just a technical report; it is the philosophy of life in Mithila. The conclusion of Dinesh Kumar Mishra's research is that the path of

'coexistence' must be adopted instead of 'war' with the river. It is necessary to view floods as a water resource rather than a disaster.

Mithila's future depends on whether it revives its traditional knowledge of rivers or remains trapped in the web of modern engineering that ultimately leads to destruction. Dinesh Kumar Mishra's work is a cautionary torch for future generations.

Bhutahi Nadi Aur Takniki Jhad-Phook (2005)

Bhutahi Balan

Geographical Location: Bhutihi Balan is a small river in Madhubani district, Bihar, located between the Kamla and Kosi river basins. It is much smaller than the major rivers of North Bihar, but its destructive power is many times greater than its size.

'Ghostly' Nature and Uncertain Path: The river's name 'Bhutihi' comes from its unpredictable behavior. Until recently, it had no fixed bed. According to locals, this river appears suddenly during the rains, enters homes, blocks travel, and disappears before people can understand anything. After disappearing, it leaves behind a thick layer of sand, ruining agricultural land.

Drainage Problem: Since it had no fixed stream, its water would break into many small channels and spread. When the 'District Board Road' was built from Jaynagar to Narahiya in the 19th century, its bridges were unable to drain the Bhutihi Balan's water, worsening the flood devastation.

Impact on Agriculture and Economy: The Bhutihi Balan's floods completely destroy paddy crops. The accumulation of sand renders the land barren, severely damaging the economic condition of local farmers.

Myths and Legends: Folklore says that when the Kosi and Kamla changed their courses, Bhutihi Balan established its kingdom in the empty space between them. It is considered like a 'wandering ghost' that never stays calm.

Beginning of Embankment Construction: Under pressure from the public distressed by the Bhutihi Balan's devastation, the government formulated a plan in the 1960s to control it. Under this, embankments were built on both sides of the river to keep the water flowing in a fixed course towards the Kosi, preventing it from spreading into villages.

Serious Problem of Silt: The chapter identifies 'silt' as the biggest reason for 'engineering failure'. The Bhutihi Balan brings so much sand that the path between the embankments quickly fills up. When the riverbed fills with sand, the water breaches the embankments and flows out. For engineers, this has become like 'witchcraft' where only temporary repairs are done instead of addressing the root cause.

Railway and Road Obstruction: The North Eastern Railway line is a major obstacle in the Bhutihi Balan's path. The capacity of the railway bridges (Bridge Nos. 33-40) is insufficient to handle the river's heavy discharge and sand. This causes water to backflow towards the rear, flooding new areas.

Displacement and Rehabilitation: There was no concrete rehabilitation policy for the people who got trapped 'inside' after the embankment construction. People became insecure on their own land. The government limited flood management to 'relief distribution', while permanently routing the sand was necessary.

Kingdom of Sand: The Bhutihi Balan's specialty is that it brings more sand than water. This sand accumulates in the riverbed so quickly that the embankment's height becomes insufficient. When the river fills its own path with its sand, it seeks a way into new areas, keeping the risk of breach constant.

'Engineering Witchcraft': Engineers want to control the river's water, but they fail to manage the sand. The process of building embankments without properly

routing the sand is called 'witchcraft' by the author, where only the symptoms are treated instead of the root cause.

Role of Railways and Technical Hurdles: The railway bridges (Bridge nos. 33-40) in the Bhutihi Balan area are getting filled with sand. Due to lack of coordination between the Railway administration and the Water Resources Department, the river's water backs up towards the rear. This disrupts railway services and creates a permanent waterlogging problem in surrounding villages.

Lack of Rehabilitation: The plight of displaced people is described. For people trapped inside the embankments, 'disaster management' is limited to distributing relief materials. There is no concrete policy for their future security or for preserving the fertility of the land.

According to the author, controlling the Bhutihi Balan is impossible as long as we do not route the sand instead of just the water. The final decision is made by the river, and to escape that 'decision', we need to understand nature's behavior instead of fighting it. In short, the third chapter warns that the problem with Bhutihi Balan is not just 'flood' but 'sand'. If the technical approach does not change, this 'ghost river' will continue its destructive game.

Lessons from Engineering Failure: According to the author, the 'embankment' experiment on the Bhutihi Balan failed. The main reason was that engineers failed to route the sand, which was more than the water. As long as the sand is not routed, no embankment can stop the river's destructive power.

Railway and Administrative Coordination: Coordination between the Railway and Water Resources Department is crucial to increase the capacity of the railway bridges (Bridge Nos. 133-140). If water and sand can flow out without obstruction, the devastation in surrounding villages could be reduced.

Beyond Disaster Management: Currently, the government considers only 'relief distribution' as the solution. The author argues that this is just a 'band-aid', not a cure. A clear policy of 'displacement and rehabilitation' is needed for a

permanent solution, where people trapped between embankments get safe places and means of livelihood.

Subduing the 'Ghost' vs. Harmony: The attempt to 'subdue' Bhutihi Balan is called 'witchcraft' by the author. He says that instead of fighting nature, we need to understand its behavior and adapt our lifestyle (e.g., house construction, farming methods). The author says the final decision is made by the river. If we remain in technical arrogance, destruction is certain. A solution is only possible when we accept the river's fickleness and try to harmonize with it. In short, the fourth chapter views Bhutihi Balan as a 'warning' that forces us to make a radical change in our water management policy.

In this book, Dinesh Kumar Mishra narrates the story of Bhutahi Balan, a small but highly destructive river in Madhubani district. This river flows between the Kamla and Kosi. It is called "Bhutahi" (ghostly) because it has no fixed course; it appears suddenly during the rainy season, devastates villages and homes, and then disappears, leaving behind sand.

The author's main attack is on the methods of government engineering, which considers embanking the river as the only solution without understanding its natural behavior.

In the 1970s, the government built embankments only on the western side. The result was that while leaders of the western area (like some powerful leaders from Phoolparas) saved their region, the river became a curse for 54 villages in the eastern part.

Destruction of Natural Balance: Earlier, the river's water used to bring fertile soil (silt), but due to the embankment, now only sand accumulation occurs, completely ruining agriculture.

The book shows how a wrong technical decision divides society into two parts. The people inside the embankment oppose the construction of the eastern embankment because they fear that building it will increase the river's pressure

on their side. When work on the eastern embankment started in 1996, people from both sides fought, resulting in deaths.

The author argues that engineers see the river's "water" but ignore its "sand and silt". When the river's sand accumulates between the embankments, the riverbed rises, and the embankment's breach becomes certain.

The rehabilitation of villages trapped between the embankments exists only on paper. Institutions like the Kosi Vikas Pradhikaran are almost defunct. The author clearly states that the construction of embankments nurtures the 'alliance' of contractors, engineers, and politicians more than serving public interest.

Bhutahi Balan: Geographical Speciality and the Mystery of 'Ghostly' Nature: Bhutahi Balan is a very unique and small stream of the Kosi river system, known for causing far greater destruction than its size. Flowing in the Phoolparas and Ghoghardiha areas of Madhubani district, this river lives up to its name 'Bhutahi' (ghostly). According to local villagers, this river behaves like a 'ghost' – it appears suddenly in the rainy season, submerges entire villages, and disappears in a short time, leaving behind only a thick layer of sand.

River Morphology and Dynamics: The hydrological character of Bhutahi Balan differs from other North Bihar rivers. Some of its main features are as follows:

1. High Silt Load: Originating from the Shivalik range of the Himalayas, this river carries a huge amount of sand. When water spreads, sand accumulates in the fields, turning fertile land barren.

2. Channel Instability: Bhutahi Balan has no permanent 'bed'. It flows in a meandering pattern and keeps changing its course every year.

3. Obstruction by Western Embankment: After the construction of the Kosi's western embankment, the natural drainage of Bhutahi Balan was blocked. This river is now forced to flow parallel to the Kosi embankment, causing severe waterlogging.

From a geographical index perspective, analyzing the Kosi and its tributaries reveals their destructive potential. Some formulas used in hydrological studies are:

• Dissection Index: Indicates the vertical erosion of the river.

• Ruggedness Index: This index is very high in the Bhutahi Balan area, indicating its youthful and aggressive nature.

Dr. Dinesh Kumar Mishra's book was published in 2004. In it, the author uses the term 'Engineering Witchcraft' sarcastically, attacking the mentality of government engineers who believe they can control a natural force like a river by performing 'witchcraft' with embankments.

Bhutahi Balan River:

• Historical introduction of the river and its place in Mithila's culture.

• Changing course: How this river has changed its path over time.

• Compulsion of embankments: Description of the circumstances in which the government decided to build embankments.

• Initial efforts: Initiatives taken for embankments in the 1960s.

• Post-construction landscape: New problems arising after the embankments were built.

• Dharmakshetre Kurukṣetre: Conflict between villagers for and against the embankment.

• Embankment – Ignorance or Conspiracy?: Sociological analysis of technical failure.

• Judicial Intervention: Court proceedings on the expansion of the embankment.

• The River Renders Final Judgment: Author's firm belief that nature is the ultimate arbiter.

• Relevance of Traditional Methods: The old way of harmonizing with floods.

• Rehabilitation of Displaced People: The plight of people trapped between embankments.

• Need for Caution: A warning for the future.

• Advocacy for a New Water Vision.

Concept of 'Engineering Witchcraft': The author's main argument is that engineers attempted to control only the water instead of managing the river's sand. He writes, "The engineers instead of routing the river's sand routed the water." As a result, the accumulation of sand in the riverbed raised its surface, rendering the embankments ineffective. This is like witchcraft that treats only the surface symptoms without understanding the disease.

Politics of Embankments and Social Fragmentation: The history of embankment construction on Bhutahi Balan is linked to the Emergency (1975-77). According to Dr. Mishra, the western embankment was built when civil rights were suppressed, and vocal opposition was impossible.

Enmity between Villages: The embankment construction divided villagers into two parts: those in the 'protected' area of the embankment, and those who came into the 'submerged' area due to it. This created enmity between different tolas of the same village. In several villages of Phoolparas block, supporters and opponents of embankment expansion became thirsty for each other's blood.

| Affected Village | Situation / Plight |

| : | : |

| Ghoghardiha | Village crushed between the politics of inside and outside the embankment |

| Phoolparas | Displacement of government offices due to the river's course change |

| Ramnagr-Suriahi | Panchayat that vocally opposed the expansion of the embankment |

| Ghogpur | Village made 'water prisoner' at the confluence of Kosi and Balan |

| Brahmour/Bathnaha | Fields inside the embankment destroyed by sand |

| Shambhuganj | The most vocal opposition to the embankment |

Political Interests and the Relief Industry: In Bihar, floods have become a big 'Relief Industry'. Dr. Mishra clarifies that as long as floods persist, the path for corruption in the name of relief remains open. Embankment breaches are like

'golden geese' for engineers and contractors, as crores of rupees are siphoned off in the name of repairs.

River Terminology in Mithila's Folk Culture: A distinct aspect of Dinesh Kumar Mishra's writing is that he defines rivers not just with hydrological data but through Maithili vocabulary. English has only the word 'Flood', but Maithili has precise words for different stages of flood.

Hierarchy of Flood Intensity: In Maithili folk life, flood is divided into the following five categories:

1. Badh: Normal rise in water level that increases field fertility.
2. Boha: Water that flows in, affecting village paths.
3. Sah: Flood that stays for some time, and people get used to living in it.
4. Humma: Severe flood that comes once in 25 years, water entering the threshold.
5. Pralay: Catastrophe, seen once in a lifetime.

There is a famous Maithili saying regarding the Balan river: "Ebo balan ta badhbo daalan, jebo balan ta ghatbo daalan" (If the Balan comes, the granary will increase; if the Balan goes, the granary will decrease). This saying shows how rural people understood the economic prosperity linked to floods. When water spread over fields, it brought silt, acting as natural fertilizer. But embankment construction stopped this cycle, and now floods only bring destruction.

Technical Failure and Environmental Crisis: According to Dr. Mishra, 9,410 square kilometers of North Bihar is affected by waterlogging. This situation arose due to embankments blocking the drainage of rainwater.

Silt and Rising Riverbed: The irony of Himalayan rivers is that they carry the highest amount of silt globally. The silt load in the Kosi and Balan is far higher than in the Ganga. When these rivers are confined between two walls (embankments), the silt settles on the riverbed. Gradually, the riverbed rises above the surrounding land.

Dr. Mishra's analysis can be understood through hydrological parameters:

• Dissection Index: High value indicates the intense erosional capacity of North Bihar rivers.

• Siltation Velocity: When water stagnates between embankments, the rate of sand accumulation increases.

The result is that when an embankment breaches, water enters villages from a great height, causing far greater devastation. The 1987 flood was the most severe in North Bihar's history, with embankment failure being the main cause.

Destruction of Wetlands: Madhubani district has a rich tradition of chaurs (wetlands) and ponds. These were natural sponges that absorbed excess floodwater. However, due to modern agriculture and urbanization, these wetlands have been destroyed. Between 1975 and 2022, a massive decline in wetlands has been observed in Madhubani, increasing the risk of floods.

Politics of Floods and the Endless Game of Corruption: Dr. Mishra's book "Bhutahi Balan" also highlights the failure of political leadership. He analyzes the tenures from Lalit Narayan Mishra to Karpoori Thakur and Jagannath Mishra.

Suppression of the 'Nagmani Report': Dr. Mishra mentions that during Karpoori Thakur's government, the 'Nagmani Committee' was formed to study the problem of Bhutahi Balan. This report suggested changing the alignment of the embankment, but it was suppressed after the government fell. This shows how technical solutions are ignored for political interests.

Corruption's 'Collusion': Crores of rupees are spent annually on embankment repairs. When an embankment breaches, engineers and leaders escape by calling it a 'divine calamity'. Dr. Mishra sarcastically writes that engineers have no concern for the river's behavior; their focus is only on concrete and sandbags.

The 'Leather Coin' of Human Sensitivity: Dr. Mishra's specialty is that he dedicated his entire life to rivers. He is unmarried and has devoted all his wealth and time to studying rivers. He says the title of his autobiography would be "The Leather Coin", a symbol of Mithila's struggle where valuable things have lost their value.

His work 'Barh Mukti Abhiyan' is not just an organization, but a social movement connecting people to their pre-embankment identity. He considers the 'traditional knowledge' of rural people higher than modern engineering, not treating them as laymen.

Dr. Dinesh Kumar Mishra's "Bhutahi Balan" warns us that if we try to control nature by strangling it, nature will find its own path. The 'ghost' of Bhutahi Balan is actually a product of the technical hubris that views a river merely as a pipe.

Suggestions:

1. De-commissioning of Embankments: Wherever possible, remove embankments and allow the river to spread into its natural floodplain.

2. Culture of Living with Floods: Government policy should emphasize flood 'management' instead of 'control'.

3. Integration of Folk Knowledge: The advice of local flood historians and village elders should be made mandatory in any water scheme.

4. Revival of Wetlands: Chaurs and ponds should be rejuvenated to absorb 'extra' water during floods.

5. Transparent Governance: Social audits should be arranged to curb corruption in embankment repairs.

The story of Bhutahi Balan is the plight of every river in Mithila. Dr. Dinesh Kumar Mishra's work inspires us to reconnect with our roots and harmonize with nature. If we do not wake up today, our villages and culture will be reduced to mere headlines of 'flood relief' in newspapers. The liberation of the river is our liberation.

Dui Patan Ke Bich Mein – Kosi Nadi Ki Kahani (2006)

Failure of Flood Control and Policy Irony

Data Contradiction: Author Dinesh Kumar Mishra notes that in 1954, the total length of embankments in Bihar was only 160 kilometers, and the flood-affected area was 2.5 million hectares. By 2002, the embankment length increased to 3,430 kilometers, but surprisingly, the flood-affected area also increased to 6.88 million hectares. This data proves that embankments failed to stop floods.

British vs. Modern Policy: British rulers believed that the Himalayan rivers of North Bihar carried excessive 'silt', making it dangerous to dam them. They emphasized 'drainage' more. However, after independence, bypassing technical and administrative debates, the 'adventurous' but wrong decision was made to build embankments on a large scale.

Technical and Administrative Failure: According to the author, 'flood control' has now become merely a matter of 3 months (rainy season). Politicians aim to keep the discussion limited to 'relief' (polythene, rations, matches). The technical community (engineers) tries to shirk responsibility, and when an embankment breaks, it is dismissed as a 'divine disaster' and files are closed.

Tampering with Nature: The essay clarifies that confronting the river with arrogance yields no benefit. The hubris of trying to subdue nature is the cause of destruction. Simply renaming 'flood control' as 'flood management' does not solve the problem as long as we do not respect the natural flow of the river. As long as the flood debate does not move beyond salt and candles to fundamental policy, the situation will remain 'as is'. People see this tragedy as a 'nightmare' and forget it, giving the administration no pressure to correct its mistakes. 'Embankment-based development' is a major failure; 'living with the river' is what is needed.

Dui Patan Ke Bich Mein

Mythological Tale: In the Puranas, the Kosi is called 'Kaushiki'. It is considered the form of Sage Vishvamitra's sister Satyavati, who took the form of a river after her great departure. Its glory is also described in the Valmiki Ramayana and Mahabharata, where it is called 'Shakti-rupa' and 'Punyamyi'.

Death's Penance: According to a Mahabharata story, when Death was created in the universe, she performed intense penance on the banks of this Kaushiki river to avoid the work of destruction.

Origin of the River: The Kosi originates from the Himalayas at an altitude of about 7000 meters. Its main catchment area is in Nepal and Tibet.

Saptakosi: In Nepal, it is called 'Saptakosi' because it is formed by the confluence of seven rivers (Indravati, Sunkosi, Tamba Kosi, Likhu Kosi, Dudh Kosi, Arun Kosi, and Tamar Kosi).

Entry into Bihar: It enters Indian territory near Hanumannagar, Nepal, and flows through Supaul, Saharsa, Madhepura, and meets the Ganga at Kursela in Katihar.

Course Change: The Kosi is famous for changing its course. Over the last 250 years, it has shifted about 150 kilometers from east to west.

Problem of Silt: The huge amount of sand and silt from the Himalayas raises the riverbed, causing the river to abandon its old course and create a new one.

Old Courses: The Kosi has several abandoned courses (Chhadan Dharas) like Parman, Bhensna, Kajri, Dulardeoi, Kamla Kosi, and Dhaus Kosi.

Bihar's Sorrow: The Kosi's floods cause massive devastation. It fills fertile fields with sand, destroying their productivity.

Social Impact: The Kosi is a 'permanent terror' in people's lives. Diseases (malaria, cholera), unemployment, and migration are common due to the Kosi's floods.

Myths and Beliefs: Folklore considers the Kosi a 'virgin and fickle maiden' who does not want to be bound by anyone.

Traditional Knowledge: Initially, people used to build small 'ring bunds' around their homes and villages for protection, allowing floodwater to spread over larger areas, bringing fresh soil and fertility to the fields.

Beginning of Embankments: British rulers started building high embankments on both sides of the river to protect their trade and administrative facilities (like rail and road). British officials observed that after embankments were built, silt accumulated in the riverbed, raising its water level and increasing the risk of breach.

Kolkata Flood Conference (1897): Controlling the Kosi was considered a difficult task at the 1897 'Kolkata Flood Conference', and experts opposed building embankments on it.

Patna Flood Conference (1937): A proposal was made at the 1937 Patna Flood Conference to build a high dam at 'Barahkshetra' in Nepal on the Kosi for flood control and electricity generation.

Post-Independence: After independence, in 1947, C.H. Bhabha presented a detailed blueprint for the Barahkshetra scheme, but it kept getting postponed due to high cost and technical difficulties.

The Kosi Scheme and Decision on Embankments (1953): Ultimately, instead of the Barahkshetra and Belka reservoir schemes, the government decided in 1953 to build a barrage at Birpur and embankments on both sides of the river. This decision was primarily political, as the government lacked the funds for a high dam and wanted to provide immediate relief to the public.

Experts' Warning: Experts like Sir Claude Inglis warned that building embankments without silt control could prove dangerous in the future.

Chinese Visit and Misleading Report: Kanwar Sen and Dr. K.L. Rao visited China's Hwang Ho (Yellow River). Upon returning, they advocated for embankments on the Kosi, but did not mention that embankments had also breached many times in China, causing massive devastation.

Changing Role of Engineers: The engineers who opposed embankments in the 1930s started supporting them in the 1950s under political pressure.

Inauguration of the Kosi Scheme: The foundation stone of the Kosi Scheme was laid on 14 January 1955. Its main objectives were: construction of a barrage at Hanumannagar (Nepal), building embankments on both sides of the river, and constructing canals for irrigation.

Public Participation and 'Shramdan': A major feature of this scheme was 'public participation'. At the call of the then government and the Bharat Sevak Samaj, hundreds of thousands of ordinary people, students, and volunteers worked with their hands to cut soil and build the embankments. It was presented as a 'national yajna', making people feel they were protecting themselves.

Extension of Construction Work: The target was to build embankments 125 km long on the eastern side and 12 km on the western side. By 1963, the main barrage and embankments were completed. This raised hopes of flood protection in Saharsa, Supaul, and Madhepura areas.

Tragedy of Displacement: 300+ villages and about 2-3 lakh people got trapped between the river current and the embankments. The government promised them rehabilitation, but the scheme was never fully successful. For these people, the situation in 'independent India' turned hellish.

Technical and Financial Aspects: Crores of rupees were spent on this scheme. A township was built in Birpur, and the Kosi Project was considered Bihar's largest engineering project.

Initial Enthusiasm and Subsequent Disillusionment: Initially, it seemed the Kosi was controlled, but as time passed, silt accumulated inside the embankments, the water level rose, and the risk of breach increased.

Breach of Embankment – An Eternal Truth: According to the author, the breach of an embankment is an eternal truth like death; it can be postponed but not prevented. This risk persists in unruly rivers like the Kosi.

Major Breach and Devastation Events:

• Dalwa Breach (1963): The first major breach in the Kosi embankment occurred at Dalwa in Nepal. This incident soon after the barrage construction raised questions about engineers' capabilities.

• Jamalpur Submergence (1968): Unseasonal heavy rains on 5-6 October 1968 brought 9.13 lakh cusecs of water into the Kosi. The western embankment broke at 5 places near Jamalpur, submerging over 150 villages and causing immense loss of life and property.

• Bhatniya Approach Bundh (1971): The approach bundh built in Basantpur block of Supaul at the insistence of villagers breached in the 1971 flood, causing many villages to be abandoned.

• Other Major Events: Bahuarwa breach (1980), Nauhatta breach (1984), and Joginiya breach in Nepal (1991).

Administrative Insensitivity and the 'Rat-Jackal' Argument: After the 1968 Jamalpur breach, a government inquiry blamed 'jackal burrows' and 'rat holes'. People protested even in parliament, accusing the government of blaming animals for its negligence.

Endless Pain of Displacement: Whenever the embankment breaks, even people in the 'protected' area outside become homeless. Those inside were already living a hellish life, but after a breach, the condition of those outside becomes similar.

Conception and Objectives of Canals: Under the Kosi Scheme, the Eastern Kosi Main Canal was built to irrigate over 1.8 million acres in Purnia, Saharsa, and Katihar. The government promised a 'Green Revolution' and a manifold increase in food grain production.

Silt Problem: The biggest problem after canal construction was the heavy silt load in the Kosi's water. This silt began accumulating in the canal bed. The canal's capacity was reduced. Irrigation of even 2-3 lakh acres became difficult against the target of 18 lakh acres.

Waterlogging Tragedy: The canal and embankment network blocked the natural drainage system. Consequently, water did not reach areas needing irrigation, but low-lying areas experienced year-round waterlogging. Lakhs of acres of fertile land turned into swamps, worsening farmers' conditions.

Adverse Effect on Agriculture: Initially, canal irrigation benefited some areas, but later, soil salinity ('reh') increased. The Kosi's sand, reaching fields via canals, destroyed their fertility.

Corruption and Government Indifference: Massive corruption occurred in canal cleaning and maintenance. Crores of rupees were spent annually on 'silt removal', but no major improvement was observed on the ground.

Western Kosi Canal – Background and Delay:

• Lack in 1953 Scheme: The 1953 main Kosi scheme initially had no mention of the Western Kosi Canal; it was added later.

• Nepal's Consent: A large part of the canal passes through Nepalese territory, requiring Nepal government's approval.

• Foundation Stone: The foundation was first laid in 1957, but work was delayed for decades due to political and technical hurdles.

• Proposal for Dgarmara Barrage: When Nepal's consent was delayed, India proposed building a separate barrage at Dgarmara, but it was later rejected, and work continued on the old plan (canal from Hanumannagar Barrage).

Environmental and Social Impact:

• Land Acquisition: Thousands of farmers lost their fertile land to acquisition, leaving small farmers landless.

• Waterlogging: Like the eastern canal, the western canal also caused severe waterlogging, blocking natural drainage.

• Adverse Situation: In the 1987 flood, the Western Kosi Canal was devastated, causing trapped water from the north to flood the villages in between.

• Current Situation and Distance from Target: The canal is far from its irrigation target, currently achieving only about 7 percent of it. Technical complexities due to railways, roads, and tributaries have increased obstacles rather than improving farmers' facilities.

Hell Inside the Embankments:

• Tragedy of 380 Villages: When embankments were built on both sides of the Kosi, the width between them ranged from 5 to 16 km. Over 380 villages and about 8-10 lakh people (as per 1950s estimates) got trapped.

• Promise of Rehabilitation and Betrayal: The government promised to resettle those inside the embankments safely outside. But the rehabilitation plan was never fully implemented. Some villages received no land, while those that did lacked basic facilities like water, roads, and schools.

- Problems in Education, Health, and Communication: For people inside the embankments, 'development' is a meaningless word. For 4-5 months of the year, they are cut off from the world. There are no means to reach a hospital in case of illness. School buildings either wash away or teachers cannot reach.

• Struggle of 'Inside' and 'Outside': The situation of these villagers is like grain trapped between two millstones (embankment and river). When flood comes, they take shelter on the embankment, struggling with the administration and people outside.

• Administrative Neglect: The chapter states that the government machinery has accepted that the fate of these people is to 'drown'. Crores are spent on the Kosi Project, but there is no concrete policy for their safety.

Embankments – A Failed Alternative:

- Embankment Age and Silt Problem: The biggest weakness of embankments is 'silt'. The Kosi brings huge amounts of sand and soil. Trapped inside, this silt accumulates on the riverbed, causing it to rise above the surrounding land. This reduces the embankment's safety, forcing periodic height increases – an endless process.

• Obstruction of Drainage: An embankment acts as a wall, not only preventing the Kosi's water from going out but also blocking rainwater and tributaries from joining the Kosi. The result is waterlogging, turning areas outside the embankments into swamps and ruining agriculture.

- Increase in Flood-Affected Area: Government data shows that the flood-affected area in Bihar, which was 2.5 million hectares in 1954 (before embankments), increased to 6.8 million hectares by 2004 after the embankment network spread. So, 'flood control' led to an increase, not decrease, in flood area.

• Maintenance and Corruption: Crores are spent on embankment maintenance annually, making it a 'source of income' for engineers and contractors. Large sums are often embezzled in the name of 'emergency' during floods.

• People's Resistance: The chapter mentions several incidents where, during floods, affected people tried to cut embankments to save their villages. The embankment started a 'water war' between people of different areas.

- Limits of Embankments and Dams: The author clearly states that embankments and large dams are not permanent solutions for flood problems. When an attempt is made to dam a river, it strikes back with greater force and velocity. Citing examples from Gujarat and Maharashtra, the author says that even where the most dams exist, severe floods occur.

- Mirage of 'High Dam': Regarding the talk of building a 'high dam' at Barahkshetra in Nepal, the author is skeptical. He says it could increase destructive power, and the silt problem would remain. Selfish elements and institutions invested in dam construction advocate for it, but society pays a heavy price.

• Importance of Traditional Knowledge: People in the Kosi region possess rich traditional knowledge about dealing with and living with floods (e.g., house construction, specialized farming, use of boats). Modern science must not ignore this tradition but work in conjunction with it.

- Path to Solutions: Solutions for flood-affected areas differ from drought-affected ones. Planning cannot be done for individual villages but at a regional

level, based on 'clusters of villages'. Improving drainage, raising village platforms, and providing clean water/health facilities should be priorities. The author says no readymade development formula applies to the Kosi. A new model must be developed by integrating traditional knowledge with modern technology. The sooner this is done, the better for Mithila.

Historical and Geographical Introduction of Kosi: Kosi has mythological significance, being considered the wife of sage Richika, Satyavati, or the sister of Vishwamitra, 'Kaushiki'. Geographically, due to its fickleness and tendency to change course, Kosi is called 'Bihar's Sorrow'. Over the last 250 years, Kosi has shifted its main course about 120 km west, devastating a large part of Mithila.

Politics of Embankments and Engineering Failure: Mishra ji describes in detail how the political decision to build embankments on Kosi was made in the 1950s. The government initially talked about building a high dam at 'Barahkshetra' but ultimately chose embankments as a 'cheaper' option. Engineers cited examples from China's Hwang Ho and America's Mississippi to advocate for embankments, even though those techniques had already failed in those countries.

'Between Two Millstones' – The Public's Tragedy: The book's title refers to the over 300 villages and about 1 million people 'imprisoned' between the eastern and western embankments of the Kosi. For these people, flood is not a seasonal event but a permanent curse. Inside the embankments, the riverbed is rising, making the flood's fury worse each year.

Canal and Drainage Problems: The eastern and western Kosi canals, built for 'irrigation', obstructed the natural drainage paths. This turned thousands of hectares into permanent waterlogged land.

Inhuman Engineering: Dinesh Mishra argues that the Kosi project was a 'man-made' disaster. Engineers failed to correctly estimate the Kosi's silt load. As silt accumulates inside the embankments, the river rises, making a breach inevitable. According to the author, this is not a solution but a postponement of the problem for the future.

Political Interests vs. Public Welfare: Mishra ji clarifies that the decision for embankments was 'political', not 'technical'. Leaders appeased the public by claiming embankments would end floods, ignoring the serious issues of rehabilitation and displacement. Research reports from Poona were manipulated under political pressure.

The Endless Cycle of Displacement: A major criticism is that the government forgot the people living inside the embankments. 'Rehabilitation' for them existed only on paper. Many times, people themselves, frustrated, cut the embankments to escape waterlogging.

Lack of Alternatives and Corruption: The book also criticizes the emergence of a large corruption syndicate (engineer-contractor-politician) in Bihar in the name of 'flood control' and 'relief'. The money spent annually on embankment maintenance could have been used for major infrastructure. The author advocates 'living with floods' and utilizing local knowledge, which the modern system has completely neglected.

'Dui Patan Ke Bich Mein' is not just a book; it is a cry exposing the historical injustice done to the people of Mithila. Dinesh Mishra clearly states that as long as we try to fight nature (Kosi) and 'imprison' it, we will not escape destruction. The book shows how despite building over 3,430 km of embankments, Bihar's flood-affected area increased. The lure of the 'Barahkshetra' dam was used to trap people between embankments, a punishment the people of Mithila are still suffering.

Geo-scientific and Social Discourse of the Kosi Basin: The hydrological structure of North Bihar and the place of the Kosi river in its socio-economic life has been central and controversial. In this context, Dr. Dinesh Kumar Mishra's book 'Dui Patan Ke Bich Mein: Kosi Nadi Ki Kahani' is a seminal work that not only analyzes the technical aspects of the river but also voices the cultural and human tragedy of the region. This book, written by Dr. Dinesh Kumar Mishra, a Fellow of the People's Science Institute (PSI), was released on May 14, 2007, in Patna by the Chairman of the Bihar Legislative Council, Prof. Arun Kumar. This book attempts to present a people-centric perspective on the

technical and social dimensions of the annual floods in the Kosi basin, aiming to initiate a meaningful dialogue between politicians, bureaucrats, technocrats, and the affected public.

Geo-scientific Uniqueness and Historical Context of the Kosi River:

The Kosi river, often called 'Bihar's Sorrow', is considered one of the world's most challenging rivers due to its unique geomorphological characteristics. It is known for carrying a huge amount of silt, resulting in rapid changes in its course. Research shows that the area the Kosi traverses receives an average of 1456 mm of rainfall, making its flow and sediment management even more complex. Historically, the Kosi's flow used to spread over a vast fan-shaped plain, where it naturally dissipated its energy and spread fertile soil for agriculture.

Dr. Dinesh Kumar Mishra takes recourse to historical records to understand the character of this river. The book mentions that in the 12th century, King Lakshmana II built a dam on the Kosi, called 'Bir Bandh', for which the people gave him the title 'Bir'. Remains of this ancient embankment can still be seen in the Kosi area, showing that human efforts to control the river are centuries old. Similarly, accounts from 1354 describe the horror of the Kosi when Firoz Shah Tughlaq's army was returning from Bengal to Delhi; the army had to use rows of elephants and ropes to cross the river because the water's velocity was so high that heavy stones were carried away like straw.

Hydrology and Sedimentation Problem of the Kosi Basin:

The Kosi's biggest problem is its excessive sediment load. When the river emerges from the mountains into the plains, its slope decreases, reducing its carrying capacity and causing silt to deposit on its bed. This silt accumulation causes the river to keep changing its course. Modern embankment policy has interfered with this natural process.

| Major Hydrological Data of Kosi Basin | Details |

| : | : |

| Average Annual Rainfall | 1456 mm |

| Length of Eastern Embankment | 125 km (Birpur to Kopariya) |

| Length of Western Embankment | 126 km (Nepal's Bharadaha to Ghonghepur in Saharsa) |

| Number of Villages Trapped Between Embankments | 380 villages |

| Population Inside Embankments (2001 Census) | 9.88 lakh |

| Main Geo-scientific Challenge | Excessive silt load and course change |

Dinesh Kumar Mishra: From Engineer to Flood Historian:

Dr. Dinesh Kumar Mishra's personality and work herald a new paradigm in Indian river management. A graduate from IIT Kharagpur and doctorate holder from South Gujarat University, Mishra is fundamentally a structural engineer, but from 1984 onwards, he dedicated his life to studying North Bihar's rivers, floods, and irrigation. His major contribution has been through the 'Barh Mukti Abhiyan' (BMA), a network of over 700 village groups. This movement empowers communities to revive traditional, decentralized ways of living with floods and to re-establish their cultural ownership over rivers. Mishra argues that the current flood control policy based on embankments and large dams is like a 'silt-laden time bomb', ultimately proving catastrophic.

Politics of Knowledge and Traditional Approach: A significant part of Dr. Mishra's research focuses on the 'politics of knowledge'. He distinguishes between two main approaches to flood control: the modern hydrological approach and the traditional approach. The modern approach views the river merely as a watercourse and a resource to be 'tamed' through dams and embankments. In contrast, the traditional approach sees flood as a part of the life cycle and reacts accordingly. In Maithili culture and North Bihar's rural society, the river is seen as a 'mother', providing not only water but also shaping culture and communal life. Dr. Mishra notes that the colonial mentality, through engineering science, alienated communities from their rivers, establishing a relationship of control and management with nature for profit. His book 'Dui Patan Ke Bich Mein' vividly narrates this story of alienation.

The Kosi Project and the Vicious Cycle of Embankments:

The Kosi Project was initiated in 1954, aiming to protect the region from devastating floods and provide irrigation. Under this project, massive embankments were constructed on the eastern and western banks of the Kosi, largely completed by 1959. However, this construction created a new problem –

about 380 villages with nearly 1 million people became permanently trapped between these two walls.

Tragedy Inside the Embankments: The title 'Between Two Millstones' itself depicts the condition of people crushed between the eastern and western embankments. Dr. Mishra writes that these villages are spread across 13 blocks in 4 districts. For people inside the embankments, flood is an annual punishment. When the flood comes, it not only drowns their homes but also alters the size of their fields. Farmers returning to their land after the flood have to invest enormous labor and capital to clear the sand and silt layers, perpetually damaging their economic condition.

| Historical Death Rates in Kosi Region (1923-1946) | Number of Deaths |
| --- | --- |
| Malaria | 510,000 |
| Kala-azar | 210,000 |
| Cholera | 60,000 |
| Smallpox | 3,000 |
| Total Deaths | 783,000 |

These figures show that the region faced health challenges even before embankment construction, but the embankments exacerbated waterlogging issues, increasing, rather than decreasing, disease risks.

Social Impact and Challenge of Displacement: Embankment construction not only altered geography but also divided society into three categories: people trapped inside the embankments, those just outside the embankments, and those considered completely safe from flood impact. Dr. Mishra's research clarifies that embankments gave rise to 'regional environmental injustice' in North Bihar, where the risk and burden of floods were disproportionately placed on the most vulnerable sections of society, especially the Musahar and Mallah communities.

Crisis in Agriculture and Livelihood: Post-Kosi Project, agricultural activity has seen widespread change. Land productivity has been affected by silt accumulation, and the irrigation canal network often struggles with siltation. Farmers trapped inside the embankments are forced to live like refugees on their own land. In the words of one villager, "We have been serving a life sentence for 70 years." This desperation has led to large-scale migration of youth, leaving only the elderly and children in villages.

Gender and Community-based Vulnerability: The impact of floods also varies by gender. Dr. Mishra and other researchers note that women are most affected during floods due to their responsibilities for family care, food arrangements, and health challenges. For communities like the Musahars living in precarious settlements, lack of education and safe drinking water makes their situation even more dire during floods.

Kosi in Maithili Literature and Cultural Identity: Although Dr. Dinesh Kumar Mishra has written many of his works in Hindi and English, his sensibility is entirely connected to Mithila and the Maithili language. The essence of 'Dui Patan Ke Bich Mein' is to express the pain of Maithili society caused by the Kosi. Mishra is credited with writing the 'biography' of all of Mithila's rivers, including Kamla, Bagmati, Mahananda, and Bhutahi Balan.

Videha and Maithili Intellectual Discourse: In Maithili literature, the story of the Kosi is not just a geographical disaster, but a question of identity and existence. Literary magazines like 'Videha' and archives have prominently featured Mishra's work, showing that his research has become part of public literature as well as academia. His work is often seen as a powerful intervention against the bureaucrats and politicians who view the Kosi problem merely as a technical issue.

Technical Failure of Flood Control and the 2008 Tragedy:

The breach of the Kosi embankment at Kushaha, Nepal, in August 2008 is considered the biggest example of modern flood control engineering failure. Dr. Mishra had been warning for years that due to silt, the Kosi's bed was continuously rising, and embankments could not hold it for long. The 2008

event proved that even large structures like the proposed Kosi High Dam could not provide a long-term solution due to the silt problem.

Search for Alternatives: 'Living with Floods': Dr. Mishra not only critiques but also presents solutions. He advocates for reviving traditional knowledge and practices. Some of his suggested measures include:

• Revival of Ghat and Chachra: Using small seasonal dams and canals to safely drain excess water.

• Adaptive Agriculture: Using the silt deposited in fields after floods as fertilizer and choosing crops that can tolerate waterlogging.

• Community Leadership: Responsibility for flood management should be transferred from central bureaucracy to local village councils and communities.

Conclusion and Future Path: Dr. Dinesh Kumar Mishra's book 'Dui Patan Ke Bich Mein' is not just the story of the Kosi, but a serious analysis of the consequences of the modern development model. This book teaches us that harmony with nature, not conflict, is the only path to sustainable development. For the millions in the Kosi basin, the mill of 'Two Millstones' can only stop when policymakers and engineers learn to respect the river's autonomy and make affected communities partners in the decision-making process. The future of the Kosi lies not in raising embankments but in delivering justice to the millions who have lost their identity and livelihood within these structures over the past seven decades. Dr. Mishra's work is a torch in this direction, reminding us of the unbreakable bond between the river and its people that technology and politics have forgotten.

Na Ghaat Na Ghar – Refugees of the Kosi Embankments (2008)

"Refugees of the Kosi Embankments" – "Na Ghaat Na Ghar"

Kosi Tragedy and Displacement: This is a document of the inhuman conditions and endless struggles of approximately 800,000 people from 380 villages who got trapped "inside the embankments" due to the embankments built on the Kosi river.

Kosi River and Embankment Construction (1955): The Kosi is known for its fickleness and course change. After the severe 1953 flood, the government decided to build embankments to control it. When the embankments were built, it was believed that areas outside would become safe, but no serious consideration was given to the fate of people trapped "inside".

World Inside the Embankments: For people living between the two embankments of the Kosi, flood is not a "natural disaster" but an "annual feature". Every year during the rains, their homes, fields, and livestock drown in the Kosi's water. They are forced to live like "refugees" in their own country.

Failure of Rehabilitation: The original 1953 plan had no mention of rehabilitating these people. When work started in 1956, discussions occurred. The government promised land and houses for rehabilitation, but in reality, many people did not receive land, and those who did lacked water, roads, and health facilities. Many thus returned inside the embankments to live with "death".

Violation of Rights and Neglect: Author Dinesh Kumar Mishra says these people were called "sacrifices for development", but society and government turned their backs on them. Inside the embankments, education, hospitals, and employment conditions are almost zero. Their economic backbone (agriculture) is ruined.

Path to Solution: The booklet questions whether embankments actually stopped floods. The reality is that even outside the embankments, water accumulates (waterlogging), while those inside are completely devastated. Through the "Barh Mukti Abhiyan", the author calls for an open debate and the restoration of people's rights.

Conclusion: This booklet is the plight of the "invisible population" of the Kosi region, forced to be homeless on their own land due to modern engineering and misguided government policies. It is a big question mark on the "development model" that, by destroying many, claims to protect a few.

Bagmati Ki Sadgati (2010)

Bagmati Ki Sadgati!

Bagmati Story: Mythological and Cultural Significance of Bagmati:

• Origin: The Bagmati river originates from the Shivapuri mountain range, about 16 km north-east of Kathmandu, Nepal, at an altitude of about 2800 meters.

• Mythological Tale: According to the Skanda Purana, this river originated from the loud laughter of Lord Shiva. It is also called 'Vagvati' (River of Speech), which later became 'Bagmati'.

• Center of Sin-Absolution: The confluence of Bagmati and Vishnumati is considered extremely sacred. It is believed that Ravana worshipped Mahadeva at the Gokarneshwar Tirtha here. The Varaha Purana considers it a hundred times more sacred than the Ganga (Bhagirathi).

• Symbol of Fertility: According to a mythological story, the water of Bagmati has such fertile power that a Brahmin's staff sprouted after bathing in it.

Geographical Course of Bagmati (in Bihar): Bagmati enters India at Dheng (Shorwatia village) in Sitamarhi district, Bihar. Its total length in Bihar is 394 kilometers, and it ultimately meets the Kosi river near Khagaria. The author divides it into three sections: North Bagmati (Dheng to Khoiripakor), Central Bagmati (Khoiripakor to Kanauj Ghat), and South-East Bagmati (Hayaghat to Kosi confluence).

River Shifting: Bagmati is known for its fickleness and course change. According to surveys by James Rennell (1780) and William Hunter (1877), its flow path has changed historically.

Silt Problem: The river carries a huge amount of sand and soil. About 2 million tons of silt accumulate annually between Dheng and Hayaghat, raising the river's surface and forcing it to change course.

Tributaries and Adhwara Group:

• The main tributary of Bagmati is Lal Bakeya, which joins it at Khoiripakor.

• Lakhandei: This river flows through Sitamarhi town and is culturally significant as it is linked to Janaki (Sita)'s birthplace.

• Adhwara Group: A network of small rivers (Jhim, Khiroi, Rato, Dhouns, etc.) that ultimately merge into Bagmati near Hayaghat.

Traditional Approach to Floods: In Mithila's culture, flood was not always seen as a 'disaster'. People classified it as 'Boha' (normal flood), 'Humma', and 'Sah' (severe flood). Floods used to bring new fertile soil, making rabi crops 'bumper' without fertilizer. According to the author, the British started building embankments (dams) for commercial gain, turning the natural flood cycle into a 'tragedy'.

Story of Flood Control – Historical Perspective:

Bagmati is a fickle river that keeps changing its course. Citing reports of 18th and 19th-century British officers, the author says the Bagmati's flood was sometimes a boon, as it made fields fertile through 'silt'.

• Problems Arising from Railway and Road Construction: When the railway network expanded in Bihar in the late 19th century, it obstructed the river's natural flow. The railway's high embankments and narrow bridges caused water to accumulate, making floods more severe.

- The Embankment Debate: There was a major debate among British engineers about whether to build embankments. The 1897 'Calcutta Conference' concluded that embankments would cause the riverbed to rise, creating a greater future hazard. However, embankments gradually gained advocacy due to commercial interests and administrative safety concerns.

• Imitating the Post-Independence Kosi Model: After independence, when embankments were built on the Kosi, pressure increased for similar schemes on the Bagmati. Work on Bagmati embankments began piecemeal in the 1950s.

• Technical Failure and Changing Plans: Several plans for Bagmati were made and revised. There were talks of separating it from the Adhwara rivers or building a 'barrage'. But no solid master plan was finalized.

- Bagmati Project – A Review: After witnessing the Kosi's devastation in 1953-54, the government's attention turned to Bagmati. Initially, only 'small' schemes were discussed, but later it became a 'mega project'. The main objectives were

to protect Sitamarhi, Muzaffarpur, Shivhar, and Darbhanga districts from floods and provide irrigation facilities.

• Embankment Construction: Embankments on Bagmati were built in phases, from Dheng to Khoiripakor and then in downstream areas.

• Technical Oversights: According to the author, local geography was neglected while deciding embankment alignment. Engineering was prioritized over the river's fickle nature.

• Confluence of Lal Bakeya and Bagmati: The design of the embankment at the confluence of Bagmati and its tributary Lal Bakeya had major flaws, increasing flood risk in that area instead of reducing it.

• Neglect of the Adhwara Group: The interconnection of small rivers like Lakhandei, Rato, Khiroi with Bagmati was overlooked, blocking natural drainage paths.

• Displacement and Rehabilitation Problems: Like the Kosi, several villages got trapped between the Bagmati embankments. Land was acquired, but no concrete rehabilitation policy was implemented, forcing people to live 'illegally' on their own land.

• Corruption and Contractor System: The chapter makes it clear that the Bagmati project became a hub of 'corruption'. Crores were spent on embankment construction and maintenance, yet breaches continued every flood season.

The Bagmati Embankment – A Dream:

• Expansion of Bagmati Project: In the 1970s, a large master plan for Bagmati control was prepared. It aimed to build high embankments on both banks from Dheng to Hayaghat. The government claimed this would protect lakhs of acres in Muzaffarpur and Sitamarhi.

• Incomplete Construction and 'Gaps': Construction was never simultaneous and systematic. Many kilometers of embankment were left as 'gaps'. During floods, water gushed through these gaps with such force that it devastated surrounding villages.

- Local People's Resistance: Those whose land and homes fell 'inside' (river side) due to embankment construction strongly opposed it. At several places, there were violent clashes between police and people. They argued that the embankment made their lives even more insecure, as floodwater now stagnated in their villages for longer.

• 'Retired' and 'Surplus' Embankments: To correct engineering mistakes, the administration adopted the method of building another 'retired embankment' behind the old one. This further wasted land and worsened the farmers' situation.

• Corruption 'Flood': According to the author, Bagmati embankment construction and maintenance became a 'golden goose' for engineers and contractors. Weak sections of the embankment would break annually in floods, leading to the embezzlement of crores in the name of repairs.

Canal and Irrigation – A Mirage:

• Dream of Bagmati Barrage and Canal: A major part of the Bagmati scheme was 'irrigation'. A plan was made to build a barrage at Dheng in Sitamarhi district and take out eastern and western canals from it. The government claimed this would provide perennial water to lakhs of hectares in Sitamarhi, Muzaffarpur, and Shivhar, boosting yields.

- Serious Problem of Silt: Like the Kosi, Bagmati also carries a huge amount of 'silt' (sand and soil). When water was released into the canals, sand began accumulating in the canal bed. The reduced depth made it difficult for water to reach fields. Now, the canals have water, but it is useless to farmers.

• Waterlogging and Swamps: The canal network completely disrupted the region's 'natural drainage'. Rainwater, which previously drained into the river, now gets trapped in fields due to canal embankments. Thousands of acres of fertile land turned into 'chaurs' and swamps, making farming impossible.

• 'Reh' (Salinity) Problem: Prolonged waterlogging led to the accumulation of 'reh' (salinity) on the soil surface, rendering fertile land barren. Where once 'gold' was produced, now even grass struggles to grow.

• Administrative Corruption and Neglect: Crores are spent annually on canal cleaning and gate repairs, but the ground situation worsens. In many places, the canal structure is broken, causing water to flood entire villages.

World Inside the Embankments:

- 'Prisoner' Population: The embankments on both sides of Bagmati trapped several villages in between. According to the author, for these people, flood is not a natural disaster but a 'permanent imprisonment'. When water rises in the river, these villagers leave their homes and take refuge on the embankments.

- Deception of Displacement and Rehabilitation: The government promised to relocate people inside the embankments to safe places outside and give compensation. The reality is that corruption occurred in the name of rehabilitation. Many received no land, and those who did lacked basic facilities like water, roads, and schools.

• Dismal Education and Health: Schools in villages inside the embankments either wash away or teachers cannot reach. In case of illness, the only means to reach a hospital is a 'boat'. Many patients die before reaching the hospital.

- Social and Economic Exclusion: The administration considers people inside the embankments as 'neglected'. Their agriculture is completely uncertain. Conflicts often occur between people inside and outside the embankments, as those outside fear that those inside might cut the embankment for their own safety.

• Administrative Insensitivity: Government officials consider their duty done by distributing 'relief' during floods. There is no concrete policy for the permanent development of these villages.

Flood, Politics, and Administration:

- Flood and Election Connection: According to the author, flood has become a 'political opportunity' in North Bihar. Leaders do aerial surveys during floods, make grand promises, but everything is forgotten once the flood recedes. Distributing flood 'relief' has become a tool for building vote banks.

- Economy of Relief: 'Relief' has become a large 'industry'. When flood comes, crores of rupees flow from the government treasury in the name of grain, chura-gur, and polythene sheets. A large portion goes into the pockets of contractors, middlemen, and corrupt officials. Only a 'token' reaches the public.

• Administrative Negligence: 'Pre-flood preparedness' exists only on paper. Substandard materials are used in embankment repairs, causing them to break in the first flood. When an embankment breaks, the administration washes its hands by calling it a 'divine disaster'.

• Game of Government Data: Government data minimizes losses to reduce compensation. Conversely, relief material expenses are inflated.

• Making People 'Dependent': The author argues that instead of making people self-reliant (e.g., fixing drainage, new farming techniques), the government has made them dependent on 'relief'. This is destroying people's self-respect, making them wait for government aid each year.

Embankments and Public Resistance:

- Public Outrage against Embankments: When people saw that embankments were causing their fields and villages to flood more, they organized and protested. In many areas of Bagmati, people formed 'anti-embankment struggle committees'. They argued that the embankments were not blocking the river but the 'development' of the people.

- Incidents of Cutting Embankments: There are many instances where, during floods, when villages started drowning, people were forced to cut the embankments to protect themselves. This was considered a 'crime' legally, but for the people, it was a struggle for survival. This widened the gap of distrust between the administration and the people.

• Movement from Muzaffarpur to Sitamarhi: In the 1970s and 80s, large public meetings were held in the Bagmati region. People demanded more 'sluice gates' and bridges to drain the trapped water behind the embankments.

• Political Neglect and Suppression: Instead of listening to the people, the government and administration viewed the movement as a 'law and order' problem and tried to suppress it. Leaders stood with the people during elections but sided with engineers and contractors when making policies.

• Demand for Technical Alternatives: People and local activists demanded 'Bauari Bandh' (ring bunds) and restoration of natural drainage. They advocated for 'small', local solutions instead of 'large embankments'.

Where is the River's 'Sadgati' (Liberation/Good Ending)?

• Current State of Bagmati: The author says Bagmati is no longer a free river. It has been 'imprisoned' by embankments and barrages. Where floodwater used to make fields fertile, now 'waterlogging' and 'sand' (silt) are permanent problems.

- Mirage of the 'High Dam': The author warns against the talk of building a large dam in Nepal's 'Terai' region. He argues that due to Himalayan geology (earthquake zone) and heavy siltation, a large dam would be unsafe. Such a dam could cause even greater devastation in the future, rather than stopping floods.

- Harmonizing Local Knowledge and Technology: Emphasis is placed on 'traditional water management'. People of Mithila have always managed water through 'chaurs', 'ponds', and 'pyne'. Modern engineering must learn from this traditional knowledge. Instead of damming the river, its 'natural flow' must be restored.

• A New Model of Development: According to the author, 'Sadgati' is only possible when we understand the rights of the river. We need to rehabilitate people trapped between embankments, improve drainage, and develop the art of 'living with floods' instead of fighting them.

• Final Call: The author says Bagmati's liberation is only possible when the government, engineers, and people collectively respect the river's natural nature. If we kill the river, the river will also kill our civilization.

In the geographical and cultural structure of North Bihar, rivers hold the highest place. The life, agriculture, festivals, and tragedies of this region revolve around rivers. Dinesh Kumar Mishra's book 'Bagmati Ki Sadgati!' is not just a history of a river, but a document of that cruel model of modern development that, abandoning people's traditional knowledge, sowed seeds of destruction in the name of 'technical solutions'. This book details the journey of the Bagmati river from its mythological sanctity to its current 'Sadgati' (which is ironic).

At the beginning of the book, the author describes the Bagmati as it was ingrained in the public psyche. Originating from the Kathmandu valley in Nepal, this river washes the feet of Pashupatinath before entering the Bihar plains. In Mithila's culture, the Bagmati is considered no less important than the Ganga. The author notes that earlier, Bagmati was a 'free' river with no fixed path. It sometimes flowed with the currents of the 'Adhwara' group, sometimes changing its course to create new wetlands.

A large part of the book focuses on the history of embankments built on the Bagmati. According to the author, the idea of embankments started during British times, but even they considered it dangerous given Bihar's terrain. After independence, in the name of 'flood control', the Government of India erected walls of cement and earth (embankments) on both sides of the river. The author argues that:

• The embankments narrowed the river's width.

• The 'silt' brought by the river, which used to spread over fields and make them fertile, now accumulates on the riverbed.

• Consequently, the river's surface has risen above the land, making the flood risk many times greater than before.

The author terms the condition of villages trapped between the embankments as 'living hell'. Under the Bagmati project, several villages came under the embankment enclosure. During the rains, when the river swells, these people are cut off from the world. No education, no health, no safety. The author questions whether these people are not citizens of India?

Mishra ji, with an engineer's eye, highlights the technical flaws of the Bagmati project. He writes about how the Gamhariya barrage and other canal systems became mere tools for filling the stomachs of contractors and politicians. Where government reports show acres irrigated, on the ground there is only waterlogging and swamps.

The author's criticism is poignant: for us, 'development' only means concrete. In the context of Bagmati, development meant damming the river. But the author uses statistical data to prove that while the flood-affected area in Bihar in 1954 was a certain amount, it multiplied after the embankments were built. This is the biggest proof of the failure of 'modern engineering'.

Dinesh Kumar Mishra's book advocates for reviving Mithila's traditional water management systems (ahar-pyne, ponds). According to the author, the ancestors of this region knew how to deal with floods. They welcomed floods because they brought new soil. But 'modern development' treated floods as an 'enemy' and invited destruction in the attempt to stop them.

The book does not just talk about the river, but about the society that was evicted from its land. Many stories of displacement pain and the duplicity in rehabilitation are compiled here. In the author's view, the embankments not only changed the geography, but also destroyed the mutual brotherhood and customs of society.

The author's style is satirical and factual. He brings out the truth buried in departmental files. The book fearlessly depicts how the government machinery embezzles crores in the name of 'relief' and how flood has become an 'annual festival' where everyone from leaders to engineers gets rich. In the context of the Bagmati river and its embankments, the 'red stick' marks the danger point, beyond which the administration and engineers declare a flood. But in the book,

this is not just a technical tool, but a symbol of the fragmentation of power and system that tries to control the river's natural truth with its 'red stick'. This stick decides who is called 'flood' and what is 'normal'. But for the river, a stick holds no value. When the stick signals danger, a new game of corruption begins in the name of 'relief and rescue'. Here, the word 'security' changes its meaning to 'exploitation'.

'Bagmati Ki Sadgati!' is not just the story of a specific region, but offers a perspective to understand the ecological systems worldwide that are tampering with rivers.

Suggestions:

• Let the river have its path, let it flow freely.

• Focus on 'flood management' rather than 'flood control'.

• Incorporate the knowledge of local people into technical decisions.

Dinesh Kumar Mishra's work is nothing less than a 'Bible' for the people of the Bagmati region. This book warns us that if we do not wake up even now, the word 'Sadgati' will remain not just irony but a terrifying truth standing before us.

For the people of Mithila, this book is not just a source of information, but a call to save their land and water. The author's research, field visits, and technical analysis make it a 'classic' document.

Bagmati Ki Sadgati: Dinesh Kumar Mishra's Water Philosophy and a Sociological and Technical Epic of Mithila's River Management

Rivers have always held primacy at the center of Mithila's cultural and geographical consciousness. The life, agriculture, and philosophy of this region are determined by the flow of rivers. However, the framework of development adopted in the modern era obstructed the natural motion of rivers, turning them into tragedies. Dinesh Kumar Mishra's timeless work 'Bagmati Ki Sadgati' is not just the story of a river, but a serious critical document of modern India's

water management policy, especially in the context of North Bihar. Through this report, a detailed analysis of the Bagmati's geographical journey, the technical failure of embankments, the human tragedy of displacement, and the neglect of local knowledge is presented.

Dinesh Kumar Mishra's personality is entirely different from the traditional engineer who seeks solutions only in concrete and steel structures. His educational background includes prestigious institutions like the Indian Institute of Technology (IIT), Kharagpur, from which he obtained a B.Tech. in Civil Engineering in 1968 and an M.Tech. in Structural Engineering in 1970. However, from 1984 onwards, he used his technical knowledge to understand the traditional and natural behavior of rivers. The foundation of his research is not just the laboratory, but the chaurs, fields, and villages trapped within embankments in North Bihar, where he continuously traveled. Mishra ji's ideological journey started from "flood protection" and reached "living with floods". He highlights how India's flood control policy remained limited to embankment construction, causing serious environmental damage. According to him, the maintenance of these structures is in the hands of an "indifferent technocracy" incapable of understanding that investments in flood control are causing more loss than gain.

Geographical Form and Water Flow System of the Bagmati River:

The Bagmati river originates from the Baghwar in the Shivapuri range, located north of the Kathmandu Valley in Nepal. This river is not just a water stream, but the foundation of a vast civilization stretching from Kathmandu to Khagaria. In India, it enters at Dheng in Sitamarhi district, Bihar. In its journey of about 400 kilometers, it decides the fate of several Bihar districts.

The complexity and extent of the Bagmati-Adhwara group river system can be understood from the following data:

| Characteristics of Bagmati-Adhwara Group | Data |
| : | : |
| Total Catchment Area (Basin Area) | 14,384 sq km |
| Catchment Area in Bihar | 6,500 sq km |

| Main River Length (in Bihar) | 394 km |

| Average Annual Rainfall | 1255 mm |

| Irrigated Area (in Bihar) | 5,362 sq km |

| Main Tributaries | Lal Bakaiya, Lakhandei, Purani Kamla, Adhwara Group |

Bagmati is famous for its fickleness. It is known for changing its course. The severe rainfall in Nepal in 1993 (540 mm in 24 hours) is a historical witness to this river's ferocity, during which the Bagmati barrage and several bridges collapsed. However, Dinesh Kumar Mishra argues that considering this natural behavior as a "disaster" is a modern technical error. This "flow" of the river and its silt have been the source of the region's fertility.

The 'Illusion' of Embankments and Failure of Engineering:

In "Bagmati Ki Sadgati", Mishra ji portrays embankment construction as an 'illusion' that initially gives a false sense of security but ultimately becomes a cause of destruction. After the 1954 National Flood Policy, the process of "jacketing" rivers, i.e., surrounding them on both sides with embankments, began. About 450 km long embankments were built on the Bagmati.

The technical reasons for embankment failure are very clear. When a river is confined between two walls, its natural velocity increases, but it cannot spread the silt it carries over the plains. Consequently, the silt deposits on the riverbed, causing the river's bed to rise. The Kosi river's bed has risen 250 inches in the last 50 years, and the same is happening with the Bagmati. When the riverbed rises, even normal rainfall can cause the embankment to breach. The Bagmati embankment has breached 54 times so far.

This is the paradox: as expenditure on "flood control" increased, the area affected by floods also expanded. Mishra ji calls this "Engineering Witchcraft", where the solution itself becomes the problem.

Human Tragedy of Displacement: The Reality of Masaha Alam and Rehabilitation:

The truth of "Rehabilitation" is stark. Embankment construction not only imprisons the river but also evicts thousands of families from their land and identity. Mishra ji cites the example of "Masaha Alam" village in the Baiganiya block of Sitamarhi district. When the right embankment of the Bagmati was being built in 1971-72, this village got "trapped" between the embankment and the river.

The tragedy of Masaha Alam village is clear from the following table:

| Details | Statistical Facts (Masaha Alam) |

| : | : |

| Total Families (1971 Census) | 420 |

| Families Rehabilitated (by 2011) | 104 |

| Homeless Families (on roads for 40 years) | 316 |

| Main Reasons | Corruption (demand for 10% bribe), lack of land, government neglect |

The people of this village have been forced to live on the road, on the embankment, or by the railway line for 40 years. They are treated as 'encroachers' and driven away by the police. Mishra ji questions whether these people are citizens of India. The local mukhiya even suggested that if the government is revoking their citizenship, they should be ordered to go and settle in Nepal. This tragedy is not just of one village, but of hundreds trapped within embankments.

Ecological Destruction and Impact on Agriculture:

Bagmati embankments have not only destroyed people but also soil health. Previously, Bagmati's flood used to bring fertile alluvium, enabling good farming without any fertilizer. After the embankments were built, this cycle was broken.

• Water-logging: Due to embankments, water from tributaries and rainfall cannot merge into the main river. This water stagnates in villages outside the embankments for months, making farming impossible.

• Silt vs. Sand: When the embankment is intact, silt does not reach the fields, rendering the land barren. But when it breaches, the high-velocity water deposits a thick layer of sand on the fields, destroying crops.

• Fisheries and Biodiversity: Bagmati's flood used to carry fish eggs that filled the region's ponds and chaurs. These fish also protected against disease by eating mosquito larvae. The embankment destroyed this natural control mechanism.

According to Mishra ji, while calculating the Benefit-Cost Ratio, engineers often fail to account for these social and environmental costs.

Mithila's Water Culture and Forgotten Vocabulary:

Dinesh Kumar Mishra is not just an engineer, but also a 'folk historian'. In his book, he preserves the Maithili and other local vocabulary that clarifies the people's perspective on floods. This rich vocabulary is being forgotten due to modern education and the propagation of the word 'Disaster'.

| Maithili/Local Word | Meaning / Category |

| : | : |

| Boh (Boh) | Flood like a festival, slowly spreading silt over fields. |

| Humma (Huma) | Level of flood causing some inconvenience, but not life-threatening. |

| Sah (Sah) | When flood threatens animals. A situation occurring once or twice in a hundred years. |

| Pralay (Pralay) | Extremely destructive flood. |

| Chap-Chap | Water up to the ankle, considered a sign of a good crop. |

| Chaur and Mann (Mann) | Natural water storage areas that absorb excess floodwater. |

There is a famous saying in Mithila – "Pag pag pokhar, maach makhana" (Pond at every step, fish and foxnut). This saying is a symbol of Mithila's excellent water management. However, embankment construction and urbanization destroyed these ponds and chaurs, turning floods into an uncontrolled tragedy.

"The society that knew how to swim is now drowning" – Anupam Mishra's statement is also reflected in Dinesh Kumar Mishra's philosophy.

Politics, Contractorism, and the Economics of 'Flood Control':

In Bagmati Ki Sadgati, Mishra ji makes a serious accusation that 'flood control' has become an 'industry'. When an embankment breaks, crores are spent on repairs. There is a powerful nexus of politicians, engineers, and contractors with no interest in a permanent solution to floods.

According to Mishra ji, if we truly want to be free from floods, we must focus on 'management' instead of 'control'. He advocates for small dams, drainage channels, and public participation instead of embankments. The strong opposition to the third phase of the Bagmati project is because people now understand that embankments are giving them not safety, but permanent hell.

Irony and Philosophical Meaning of the Title 'Sadgati':

The book's title "Bagmati Ki Sadgati" is itself a major irony. In Indian tradition, 'Sadgati' means salvation or a good state after death. Modern engineering has brought about the 'Sadgati' (end) of the Bagmati, which was as sacred and life-giving for Mithila as the Ganga.

Mishra ji writes, 'Paropakaraya vahanti nadyah' (Rivers flow for charity). But we have imprisoned them in the jail of embankments. The river that flowed freely has now become a 'sick' water stream. For this plight of Bagmati, it is not nature alone, but our "technical hubris" that is responsible.

Alternative Solutions: Approach of the Barh Mukti Abhiyan:

Dinesh Kumar Mishra not only criticizes but also shows an alternative path through the 'Barh Mukti Abhiyan'. His main suggestions are:

• Respect Traditional Knowledge: Revive the art of living with floods that Mithila's people possessed for centuries.

• Liberation from Embankments: Wherever possible, remove embankments or connect them to local drainage.

• Decentralized Management: Decisions on water management should be made with the advice of local panchayats and villagers, not by engineers sitting in Patna or Delhi.

• Revival of Chaurs: Free natural depressions (chaurs) from encroachment so they can act as buffers during floods.

Mishra ji's philosophy is based on 'harmony with nature' rather than 'conflict with nature'. He says understanding the river's behavior is true science.

"Bagmati Ki Sadgati" is a mirror in which we can see the distorted face of our development. The story of Bagmati is not just about a river, but about the blind race of development in which we are destroying our very foundation. Dinesh Kumar Mishra's research report forces us to think whether we want to leave only embankments and barren land for the next generation?

Bagmati's salvation is possible when we give it its natural path. When Bagmati, freed from the embankment's prison, irrigates Mithila's fields with its silt, then its true 'Sadgati' (good ending) will happen. This book inspires us to become a 'society that can swim', not one that flees in fear of floods. This great work by Dinesh Kumar Mishra is an invaluable heritage of Mithila's water consciousness.

The Myth of Flood Control (2014)

"The Myth of Flood Control"

Increase in Flood Problem: The author says that globally, especially in South-East Asia, the damage from floods is increasing, not decreasing. The severe floods in India in 1978 and China in 1981 are evidence. Despite large dams and embankments, the devastation figures are not decreasing.

Failure of Embankments: Embankments are the oldest and most popular method for flood control, but they often fail.

• Rising Riverbed: Due to embankments, the river's 'silt' cannot spread outside and accumulates inside, causing the riverbed to rise above the surrounding land.

• Dangerous Breach: When an embankment fails in such a situation, water gushes out with much greater velocity, causing far more devastation than a normal flood.

Dams and Floods: Dams are considered the biggest weapon for flood control, but according to the author, this is a myth:

• Capacity Issues: During prolonged heavy rainfall, the dam's 'reservoir' fills up. To ensure dam safety, water has to be released suddenly, causing 'man-made floods' downstream.

• Silt Accumulation: Silt accumulation in the dam reduces its water storage capacity every year.

Role of Deforestation: Deforestation in hilly areas loosens the soil. With no natural system to absorb rainwater, it flows rapidly into rivers, carrying huge amounts of soil and sand, which is a major cause of floods.

Flawed Development Policy: The author argues that by building houses and factories on 'floodplains', we are inviting floods. When we tamper with nature, technical solutions merely transfer the problem from one place to another.

This essay proves that the term "Flood Control" is wrong. We cannot completely control nature. The solution lies not just in building concrete structures, but in forest conservation, proper land use, and understanding the river's natural nature.

This essay advocates harmonizing with nature rather than indulging in technical arrogance.

Dinesh Kumar Mishra's book – Pani Ka Shaap: Bihar Mein Baadh-Sukhad (2026)

Dinesh Kumar Mishra's book – Pani Ka Shaap: Bihar Mein Baadh-Sukhad

Foreword (Written by Ushakiran Khan):

• Comprehensiveness of the Study: Ushakiran Khan writes that this study by Dinesh Mishra on the flood and drought situation in Bihar after independence is comprehensive.

• Ground Reality: The author not only uses government data but also interviews those affected to find the causes and remedies for the problem.

• Perspective on Rivers: The book clarifies that despite advances in science, rivers are destroying civilization, yet we still need them.

• Warning: This book serves as a message for those engrossed in self-interest, and also a warning for the government.

Author's Note (Written by Dinesh Kumar Mishra):

• Author's Background: The author introduces himself as a civil engineer initially more concerned with project timelines and budgets than with people's pain and suffering.

• Source of Inspiration: In 1984, when the Kosi embankment broke at Nauhatta in Saharsa district and he was involved in relief work, the pain and anguish of the victims inspired him to write.

• Lack of Documents: Government departments had destroyed old documents related to the 1975 flood. Therefore, the author based his study on old newspapers and legislative assembly debates available in the Sinha Library (Patna) and the National Library (Kolkata).

• Main Conclusion: The author believes that between 1947 and 1956, the government formulated plans for large dams as flood solutions, but on the ground, people's problems (food and livelihood) remained unchanged.

• Future Resolution: The author intended to complete this document covering the 2008 Kosi embankment tragedy by 2011.

Historical Document: This book is an authentic document of floods, droughts, and government policies in Bihar between 1947 and 1956.

Author's Objective: The main objective of author Dinesh Kumar Mishra (himself a civil engineer) is to show how despite the construction of large engineering projects (like the Kosi embankment), the flood problem increased rather than decreased.

Post-1956 Situation: In his note, the author mentions his intention to cover details up to 2011 to include the 2008 Kosi (Kushaha) tragedy.

Relief vs. Livelihood: The essence of the entire book is that flood victims need not just immediate 'relief', but permanent security for their land and livelihood.

After the ten-year diary-chapters (1947-56), an appendix is provided explaining technical terms.

Struggle After Independence (1947-1956): This chapter presents a historical document of floods and droughts in Bihar in the early decades after independence. The author shows how the people of Bihar were caught between nature and the governance system between 1947 and 1956.

• Slow Pace of Kosi Project: A Kosi conference was held in Nirmali in 1947, planning an 800-foot high dam at Barahkshetra (Nepal). However, until 1956, this plan remained limited to surveys and discussions, causing great disappointment among the people of the Kosi region.

• Embankment Construction and its Consequences: After the severe 1954 flood, construction of the Kosi embankment started rapidly. However, a negative consequence was that lakhs of people trapped inside the embankments were displaced, and their homes and fields merged into the river.

• Cycle of Flood and Drought: This decade was very difficult for Bihar. The first major flood of independent India came in 1948, while severe drought conditions persisted from 1950 to 1952. Floods recurred in 1953-54.

• Governance System and Relief: Using newspapers, the author shows how government 'relief' was only a temporary band-aid, but the permanent solution for livelihood was not found.

• Interviews of Elders: Interviews with elders like Shivanath Mandal and Ramdev Das Sharma narrate the real tragedy of that time and the displacement of villages.

• Completeness of Documentation: According to the author, he prepared the first part covering 1947-1956, showing the interrelationship between government policy, people's movements, and natural disasters.

"1947: Mere ghar baadh nahi aayi, tumhare ghar aayi pareshani to hui hi na" (1947: My house didn't flood, but yours did, so you must have faced trouble): Freedom and the Problems Inherited:

While there was great enthusiasm among the people of Bihar at the time of India's independence (August 15, 1947), this period was also very painful due to partition and communal riots. The economy of Bihar was stable at independence, but the population was continuously increasing.

- Food Crisis and Fear of Famine: According to the 1941 census, 86 percent of Bihar's population lived in villages, and there was a severe food shortage. Between 1943 and 1947, the cholera epidemic and skyrocketing grain prices (rice prices rose from Rs. 5-9 to Rs. 23) were major challenges for the government.

- Historical Context of Flood and Drought: Before describing the 1947 situation, the author discusses history. Three severe famines struck Bihar in the 19th century (1865-66, 1873-74, and 1896-97). Similarly, in 1946, a sudden flood in the Phalgu river in Gaya caused massive loss of life for pilgrims and locals.

- 1947 Flood and Government Efforts: In 1947, floods occurred in Darbhanga, Muzaffarpur, Gaya, and Saharsa districts. Under the 'Grow More Food' scheme, the government focused on minor irrigation, wells, and distribution of fertilizers and seeds. To accumulate food stocks, the government strictly procured grains from traders and large farmers.

- Kosi Problem and Nirmali Conference: In April 1947, a large 'Kosi Flood Conference' was held in Nirmali (Supaul), attended by Dr. Rajendra Prasad and other experts. A proposal was made there to build an 800-foot high dam at

Barahkshetra (Nepal) on the Kosi for flood protection and electricity generation.

- People's Pain: The chapter shows the sentiment of the people: although my house didn't flood, yours did, so you must have faced trouble. This chapter presents the real picture of the administration and society in the early years of independence, struggling with floods, droughts, and food shortages.

"1948: Katate-katate 1976 me mera gaon khatam ho gaya" (1948: Gradually, by 1976, my village was destroyed):

- Background and Discussion on Kosi: In 1947, there was discussion about the Kosi, Kamla, and Gandak rivers, but the main focus was on the Kosi. After the Kosi problem and the Nirmali Conference (1947), hope arose among people that constructing an 800-foot high dam at Barahkshetra in Nepal would solve the problem.

- Concept of Irrigation and Electricity: Then Irrigation Minister Ramcharitra Singh, through radio talks, envisioned generating 1800 MW of electricity from the Kosi project and irrigation via tube wells. Governor Madhav Shrihari Aney also mentioned in the Assembly that work on the Kosi and Gandak projects was beginning.

• Severe Flood of 1948: This was the first major flood in independent India's Bihar, severely affecting Saharsa, Saran, Muzaffarpur, Darbhanga, Patna, and Shahabad districts.

• Situation in Saharsa: In Saharsa and Supaul, the Kosi and Tilave rivers rose prematurely in the last week of June, affecting over one lakh people. Rail links to Madhepura and Saharsa were cut.

• Scene in Darbhanga: In July, flooding in the Kamla, Balan, and Jivach rivers submerged Madhubani town up to 3 feet. 50,000 acres of paddy crop in the Madhepur thana were completely destroyed, forcing people to survive on chura-gur (flattened rice and jaggery).

• Devastation in Saran: The Ganga and Ghaghra (Saryu) floods in Saran district were unprecedented. Over 1000 villages were affected, and over 25,000 houses collapsed. The situation in Sitab Diyara village (Loknayak Jayaprakash Narayan's village) became critical.

- Administrative Failure and Relief: The government faced heavy criticism in the Assembly. People complained about delays in relief distribution and a

shortage of boats. This chapter includes interviews with elders like Udit Rai and Prof. Yogendra Choudhary, describing the horrific situation of that time.

This chapter depicts the struggle of Bihar's people after independence, where on one hand there was great hope from the new government, and on the other, nature's fury and administrative slowness compounded their suffering.

"1949: Relief nahi, jeevika ka sadhan chahiye" (1949: Not relief, we need means of livelihood):

• Impact of Kosi Project and Nirmali Conference: After the 1947 Nirmali Conference, people had high hopes for the Kosi Project (800-foot high dam at Barahkshetra). However, by 1949, with no significant work on the ground, frustration and anxiety grew among the people.

- Untimely Flood and Devastation: In 1949, the Kosi flooded suddenly on May 21, disrupting rail links between Daurm Madhepura and Baijnathpur. Rain started in North Bihar in the second week of June, causing severe devastation in the Madhepura sub-division (Dharhara, Banganwa, Sonbarsa) due to the Kosi-Tilave.

• Demand for "Means of Livelihood": As per the chapter's title, the people of the Kosi region felt that those struggling with year-round waterlogging and floods needed not just 'relief' but 'permanent means of livelihood'.

• Kiul Bridge Accident: In July 1949, due to heavy rainfall, the bridge over the Kiul river in Jamui was washed away. This was a major tragedy in Jamui's history.

• Irrigation and Food Situation: Development Minister Dr. Syed Mahmood stated in the Assembly that Bihar was becoming self-reliant in food production, and grain imports in 1948 had decreased compared to 1946. However, the sudden drying up of the Tiaur canal in Champaran brought a new crisis for farmers.

- Administrative Slowness and Corruption: Members of the Legislative Assembly (Pandit Buddhinaath Jha, Dev Narayan Singh, etc.) strongly criticized the slowness of the Irrigation Department and the corruption of overseers. People said the government made paper plans but no work was happening on the ground.

• Narayani Steamer Accident: On November 18, 1949, the 'Narayani' steamer, carrying about 700 passengers near Rani Ghat in Patna, met with an accident, resulting in the deaths of around 300 people.

This chapter shows that even two years after independence, the people of Bihar were looking to the government for flood protection and livelihood, but the administrative machinery's slowness did not alleviate their suffering.

"1950: Rahat baantna asal samasya ko choo bhi nahi paata" (1950: Distributing relief does not even touch the real problem):

- Kosi Project and Talk of Qutub Minar: In early 1950, there was much discussion about the future form of the Kosi Project. Engineer Pran Ranjan Guha stated in Patna that a dam three times taller than Delhi's Qutub Minar would be built on the Kosi, providing a permanent solution to the Kosi region's flood problem.

• Demand for Gandak Project: Inspired by the Kosi Project, people of the Gandak region also started pressuring the government. On January 16, 1950, the Bihar Legislative Assembly approved the Gandak Project, but work stalled due to resource shortages.

- Governor's Concern and 'Vilap Desh': Then Governor Madhav Shrihari Aney, at a conference of engineers in Patna on January 29, 1950, said North Bihar had become a 'land of tears' and 'Vilap Desh' (land of lamentation) due to floods. He said that large areas had become like deserts due to the floods of the Kosi, Kamla, and Bagmati.

• Lack of Central Financial Assistance: On February 16, 1950, the Governor told the Legislature that the central government, due to its own financial constraints, had withdrawn its assurance of financial assistance to the state. This was a major blow to Bihar's development plans.

• Goal of Food Self-Reliance: The government aimed to eliminate the food deficit by the end of 1951. Large-scale tube-well irrigation was considered for the sugarcane areas.

• Reality of Relief: According to the chapter's title, the author believes that merely distributing 'relief' during floods does not address the root cause of the problem. While some areas were devastated by drought, others were desperate for dry land due to floods.

This chapter shows that in 1950, the government was dreaming of large dams and electricity, but on the ground, people's struggle continued amidst financial constraints and natural disasters.

"1951: Hamdardi ke sandesh nahi, anaaj dijiye" (1951: Don't send messages of sympathy, give us grain):

• Severe Drought and Food Shortage: The drought that began in late 1950 took a severe form in 1951. Most of Bihar was in the grip of drought, drastically reducing food production. People's condition was so bad that they demanded 'grain' directly instead of 'sympathy'.

• External Dependence for Grain: India was dependent on foreign aid for food grains at that time. Talk of importing grain from America was ongoing, but its conditions and delays in arrival tested people's patience.

• Failure of Irrigation and Government Schemes: Under the 'Grow More Food' scheme, the government emphasized wells, ahars, pyne, and minor irrigation, but corruption and administrative slowness caused these schemes to fail on the ground. Farmers argued that paper plans don't fill stomachs.

• Slow Pace of Kosi and Gandak Projects: The initial enthusiasm for the Kosi Project was gradually turning to disappointment. Work on the Barahkshetra dam could not proceed due to the central government's financial constraints. The Gandak Project was limited to surveys.

• Relief Work and Corruption: Relief work was initiated in drought-affected areas but was insufficient. Black marketing of food grains and irregularities in ration distribution worsened the plight of ordinary people.

• Political and Social Landscape: Preparations for India's first general elections were underway in 1951. Leaders toured villages making promises, but the specter of starvation fueled anger among the people.

This chapter depicts the painful period in Bihar in 1951, where natural disaster (drought) and administrative failure combined to make life unbearable for the common populace. 'Grain' became the biggest priority for people.

"1952: Rajdhani bhi nahi de pa rahi thi zaruratmandon ko kaam" (1952: Even the capital could not provide work to those in need):

• Impact of Continuing Drought: In 1952, Bihar faced severe drought for the third consecutive year. The food shortage was so acute that even the capital, Patna, could not provide work and food to the needy.

• Food Crisis and Dependence on Foreign Aid: India was still dependent on foreign aid for food grains. The government strictly enforced grain procurement, but it was insufficient.

• Administrative Slowness and Unemployment: The chapter shows that due to the drought, farming was at a standstill, and people had no source of employment. Relief work initiated by the government was minimal compared to the number of people.

• Status of Kosi and Gandak Projects: While major projects like Kosi and Gandak were being seriously discussed, no significant progress was made on the ground. Insecurity and helplessness grew among people of the Kosi region.

• Political Landscape: After the first general elections held in 1952, a new government was formed. People hoped the newly elected government would alleviate their suffering, but the situation remained out of control due to financial constraints and natural disasters.

• Pain of Displaced People: For those displaced by floods and droughts, finding a safe place to live and a source of livelihood was a major challenge.

This chapter portrays the social and economic crisis in Bihar in 1952, where the administration was failing to meet the basic needs (work and grain) of the common people.

Post-Independence Water Crisis in Bihar: Dinesh Kumar Mishra's Pani Ka Shaap (1947-1952)

Dinesh Kumar Mishra's historical document in 'Pani Ka Shaap' is a significant repository of the socio-technical and political complexities of the Gangetic plain from 1947 to 1952. The years 1947-1952 represent a transformative era in which the nascent Indian state attempted to reconcile traditional agricultural vulnerability with modern engineering ambitions. Through a deep examination of Bihar Legislative Assembly debates, contemporary newspaper accounts, and oral histories, the story of Bihar's floods and droughts emerges not as a series of separate natural disasters, but as a continuous struggle between a changing landscape and a governance system inherited from colonial tradition.

## Historical Background and Pre-1946 Events

To understand the findings from 1947-1952, it is essential to grasp the historical frequency of disasters described by Mishra. The geography of Bihar is divided by the Ganga river into two parts: North and South. North Bihar is defined by unstable, silt-laden Himalayan rivers like the Kosi, Gandak, and Bagmati, while South Bihar is characterized by rain-fed systems like the Phalgu and Punpun, facing risks of sudden floods and prolonged droughts. Historical records show a continuous cycle of famine or flood in major districts like Purnia, Gaya, and Bhagalpur between 1770 and 1946. Gaya alone suffered severe famines in 1866, 1874, 1896, and the 1930s-40s. Similarly, floods were recorded annually in Darbhanga from 1926 to 1943, highlighting the systemic instability that the post-independence government was tasked with fixing.

## The 1946 Gaya Flood and Pitri Paksha Tragedy

The immediate psychological and administrative backdrop for the independence era was the devastating flood of September 17, 1946. Mishra identifies this event as the "last memory of British rule" for the residents of Gaya. The Phalgu river broke its banks at midnight, entering the city where over 100,000 pilgrims had gathered for the Pitri Paksha fair. Water entered the Collectorate to a depth of 2-3 feet, devastating localities like Manpur and Buniyadganj. Oral accounts from that time, such as that of 92-year-old priest Kritinath Garda, describe the flood current carrying 4-5 pilgrims on the roof of a house. Local pandas and residents used ropes and bamboo to rescue about 900 people, but official and unofficial estimates suggest over 100 lives were lost. This event gave rise to a sense of urgency in river control that dominated Bihar's politics for the next decade.

## 1947: Independence, Communal Strife, and Food Shortage

When power was transferred in 1947, the joy of independence was overshadowed by the harsh reality of a fractured agricultural economy. Mishra notes that although the Congress Party had taken administrative control in April 1946, the full burden of governance fell amidst communal riots and a food crisis in August 1947. The wholesale price of rice, which was Rs. 5-9 per man in 1941, had reached Rs. 23 per man by August 1947.

### The 'Grow More Food' Campaign and Economic Pressure

In 1947, Bihar was a food-deficit province, importing about 350,000 tons of rice and wheat annually. The 'Grow More Food' campaign, originally started for war purposes in 1942, was intensified after independence. The state government set a target of producing an additional 370,000 tons of grain by 1952. Despite this scheme, food distribution in remote areas remained a major problem. Due to the lack of a bridge over the Ganga, supplies to North Bihar had to be sent by rail and steamer, often disrupted by strikes and damage to the Mokama Ghat from the 1946 flood.

### The Nirmali Conference and the Dream of a Kosi High Dam

April 1947 was a pivotal moment in Bihar's river management history. At Nirmali (Supaul), in the presence of 60,000 flood victims, Dr. Rajendra Prasad, and Chief Minister Dr. Shri Krishna Sinha, a major solution was proposed: an 800-foot high dam at Barahkshetra in Nepal. This dam was envisioned to irrigate 3 million acres and generate 3,300 MW of power, ending the 'Kosi curse'. However, its cost—later estimated at Rs. 1.77 billion—and the technical complexities of construction in a seismic zone initiated a long period of delay and review.

### The 1947 Floods: Saharsa and Darbhanga

While high-level engineering discussions continued, the monsoon of 1947 reminded of the Kosi's instability. In July, floods submerged the subdivisions of Madhubani and Saharsa. Over 1 million people were surrounded by water in areas like Nirmali, Dgarmara, and Supaul. Local MLA Rajendra Mishra criticized the government for not providing adequate boats and medicines, leaving people forced to live on 'machans' (platforms) amidst snakes and crocodiles.

### 1948: Independent India's First Provincial Deluge

The year 1948 is documented by Mishra as the first major test of independent India's disaster management infrastructure. Continuous heavy rainfall in August and September brought disaster to the entire province, affecting almost all major river basins including the Ghaghra, Gandak, Ganga, and Kosi.

### Devastation in Saran and Chapra

In August 1948, Saran district faced unprecedented destruction. Heavy rainfall in the upper catchments of the Ghaghra and Ganga caused sudden river level rises. The Naini embankment, built to protect Chapra town, broke at several places. According to the district collector's report, over 1,000 villages were submerged, and 700 villages were completely destroyed.

Personal accounts included in Mishra's research paint a clear picture of the crisis. Udit Rai, a resident of Sitadiyara (Jayaprakash Narayan's village), recalled that all 27 tolas of his village were submerged, forcing his family to flee to Chapra by boat. Sonpur railway station turned into a refugee camp. The economic impact was massive: the bhadai crop on 50,000 acres was destroyed, and 25,000 houses collapsed.

| 1948 Saran Flood Statistics | Statistical Value |
| : | : |
| Affected Villages | 1,000+ |
| Damaged/Destroyed Houses | 25,000 |
| Crop Loss (Bhadai) | 50,000 acres |
| Embankments Breached | Naini, Mehra, Barua, Kaudimal |

Table: 1948 flood statistics for Saran district

### Vulnerability of Hajipur and Muzaffarpur

In Muzaffarpur district, the Gandak and Bagmati rivers caused widespread damage in the Hajipur subdivision. In September 1948, a boat accident at Sukumarapur killed 54 people and 6 animals. The Ganga remained at its highest level for 13 days, submerging 325 villages and destroying 17,000 houses. Government relief efforts were often hindered by administrative friction; Mishra mentions an incident in Karnauti village where people attacked a magistrate, fearing that cutting the embankment for drainage would flood their fields.

### Saharsa Sub-Division and the Tilave River

In Saharsa, the 1948 flood arrived early in June due to the Kosi and its spill channel, the Tilave. When the river suddenly turned eastward, the embankment protecting Saharsa town was breached. Rail service between Saharsa and Madhepura was suspended, isolating the town. Mishra highlights the 1948 "boat crisis," where the government had to hire private boats and I.G.N. Company steamers at cost to rescue stranded people.

### The 1948 Legislative Debate: Embankment Policy

After the 1948 flood, a heated debate occurred in the Bihar Legislative Assembly on river policy. Members like Deep Narayan Singh argued that floods could not be completely prevented and that instead of waiting for annual disasters, a permanent "institutional mechanism" for relief was needed.

Irrigation Minister Ramcharitra Singh gave a nuanced response that, according to Mishra, demonstrated the state's internal conflict. Singh acknowledged that North Bihar's rivers were geologically young and that "intervening" by building embankments would cause silt accumulation and raise river levels. He stated his policy was to limit embankments, but political pressure was such that he had already approved 14 new embankments in Saran alone.

### 1949: Legislative Disappointment and Failure of Minor Schemes

The year 1949 brought the realization that minor irrigation and flood control schemes were not working as expected. The 1949-50 budget debate revealed that elected representatives were highly dissatisfied with the efficiency of the Irrigation and Agriculture departments.

### The Baya River Scheme Debate

A major part of the 1949 debate focused on the Baya river, a distributary of the Gandak. Farmers from Champaran, Muzaffarpur, and Munger had been demanding since 1894 to restore the Baya's drainage capacity. The river was choked with silt and illegal fishing nets, causing waterlogging in 134 chaurs. In the Assembly, Jay Narayan Prasad expressed frustration that "engineers came and went, but the Baya scheme remains locked in files." This is a recurring theme in Mishra's work: the gap between technical surveys and on-the-ground implementation.

### The Kiul Bridge Collapse and Eastern Bihar

In July 1949, heavy rainfall in the southern catchment caused the Kiul river to swell in Jamui, washing away a large section of the road bridge. This event isolated the Jamui subdivision and exposed the vulnerability of the state's infrastructure to sudden floods. Similarly, in Patna district, the lack of drainage in the southern part of the city led to 30,000 bighas of land being submerged.

### Stagnation of the Kosi High Dam Project

While local floods continued, the Kosi High Dam project entered a technical stalemate in 1949. American expert Dr. Savage visited Barahkshetra and emphasized the extreme earthquake risk. Investigations revealed that building the world's tallest dam at that location would require decades of preliminary study. This technical caution disappointed Bihar's political leaders, who faced immense pressure to show progress to flood-affected people.

### 1950: Beginning of Severe Drought and Failure of 'Hathiya'

The year 1950 marked a dramatic shift in Bihar's water story. After years of excess water, the state now fell victim to severe drought due to the complete failure of the 'Hathiya' (final monsoon rains).

### The Collapse of the 'Grow More Food' Narrative

By 1950, the promise of self-sufficiency by 1952 was unraveling. The drought affected all districts of South Bihar and a large part of North Bihar. In districts like Gaya and Palamu, the ahar-pyne systems dried up as rivers had too little water to be diverted.

Development Minister Dr. Syed Mahmood defended the government in the Assembly, claiming that imports had fallen from 350,000 tons in 1946 to just 40,000 tons in 1948. However, the 1950 drought wiped out these gains, forcing the state to again seek central assistance and import international grain.

### Inundation vs. Drought: A Paradoxical State

In a strange paradox, while most of the state faced drought, parts experienced devastating floods. In August 1950, the Jiraian and Balwain rivers flooded the Bihar Sharif and Asthawan subdivisions. Thirty villages were submerged, and the local road network was cut in four places. Mishra notes that this "dual disaster" became a hallmark of Bihar's landscape: in the same season, some areas faced famine while people drowned in others.

### 1951: Famine Threat and the Control of the Kosi

Mishra documents 1951 as a year of severe human concern and a major shift in engineering policy. The drought that began in 1950 intensified, creating famine-like conditions in several districts.

### Nehru's Aerial Survey and the Birth of the Barrage Scheme

On August 20, 1951, Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru conducted an aerial survey of the flood-affected Saharsa region. Seeing the widespread water and people living on machans, Nehru is reported to have declared, "The misbehavior of this dwarf river, the Kosi, will no longer be tolerated. We must now control and subdue it."

This political intervention broke the technical stalemate. A committee of engineers from West Bengal and the central government declared the Barahkshetra high dam economically and technically "impossible" for the foreseeable future. Instead, they proposed the "Kosi Scheme," focused on a barrage at Bhimnagar and 150 kilometers of embankments on both banks. Mishra notes that this was an "extra-technical" decision to provide relief to voters, despite foreign experts warning that embankments would ultimately cause the riverbed to rise.

### The 1951 Census and Agricultural Crisis

During the 1951 census, the food shortage was severe. Farmers in districts like Bhagalpur and Amarpur were so desperate that they ate the seeds saved for the next sowing season. The state government had to open large-scale "fair price shops" and distribute taccavi (agricultural) loans to prevent starvation deaths.

### 1952: The First Five-Year Plan and Policy Stabilization

The year 1952 saw the formal start of India's First Five-Year Plan, which placed agriculture and irrigation as the foundation of national development. In Bihar, this period marked the strategic stabilization of river management policy that would define the state for the next 50 years.

### Institutionalization of Embankments

By 1952, the debate over whether to build embankments was largely resolved in favor of construction, despite the environmental warnings raised in the 1948 Assembly debate. The Gandak Project, aimed at irrigating a large part of Saran and Champaran, was formally proposed. The Kosi barrage was no longer a dream but a budgetary priority.

### Continued Vulnerability

Despite planning, the ground reality for the average farmer remained grim. Mishra's findings show that even in 1952, the state's capital, Patna, struggled to provide work for laborers affected by drought. The "Relief Syndrome"—a term by Mishra describing the shift from community self-reliance to total dependence on government aid—had fully taken root.

Marginalization of Indigenous Knowledge: A clear divide existed between 'expert' engineers and the 'common people' living in the floodplains. For centuries, Bihar's communities practiced "flood tolerance" through machans, bamboo erosion control, and ahar-pyne systems. After independence, the state adopted a "flood resistance" model based on colonial hydraulic tradition. By confining rivers between embankments, the state destroyed the community's "cultural ownership" over the river, turning it from a source of fertility into a source of terror.

Rise of the Political Economy of Relief: Mishra identifies the 1947-1952 period as the era when "relief" became a political tool. The annual ritual of floods gave rise to a "Relief Syndrome" where focus was on distributing grain and cloth instead of addressing root causes of vulnerability, such as silt accumulation in natural streams like the Baya and Tilave. The slow progress of schemes like the Baya Project shows that relief was often a simpler political path than complex hydrological restoration.

The Myth of the "Technical Solution": The shift from a high dam to a barrage scheme in 1951 was a fundamental compromise. It prioritized immediate flood "control" over sustainable river management. Mishra's analysis suggests that this decision turned the Kosi into a "silt-laden time bomb," as embankments prevented the river from depositing its silt on the plains, forcing its bed to rise above the surrounding land.

Fabricating the "Curse": The historical findings from 1947 to 1952 in Dinesh Kumar Mishra's Pani Ka Shaap highlight a missed opportunity to build a resilient Bihar. The state moved away from traditional, decentralized water management systems suited to the Gangetic plain's unstable nature. Instead, it created a top-down, embankment-heavy infrastructure that promised "control" but ultimately delivered an endless cycle of catastrophic breaches and waterlogging.

The years 1947-1952 were the "gestation period" for modern Bihar's flood crisis. The food shortages of the late 1940s and the famine threat of the early 1950s provided the moral and political justification for the engineering interventions that provided short-term security for some but created permanent hydrological risks for millions of others. By the end of 1952, the "Water Curse" was no longer just a natural phenomenon; it had become a structural feature of Bihar's statehood, etched into the landscape by earthen walls and the rising surface of its mighty rivers.

"1953: Is saal bade hon ya chhote, sab relief lene ko taiyar the" (1953: This year, whether big or small, everyone was ready to take relief):

- Severity of Floods and Changing Mentality: The year 1953 was extremely painful for Bihar. Previously, the middle class or self-respecting farmers considered taking relief a disgrace, but the severe floods and hunger of this year forced everyone. Whether small or big, all were seen ready to take government relief.

- Emphasis on Kosi and Gandak Projects: Discussions on the Kosi Project to free the region from the Kosi's devastation peaked this year. Since the Nirmali Conference on April 5-6, 1947, people had been hopeful, but the slow pace of work on the ground increased their frustration. Survey work was also ongoing for the Gandak Project.

• Parallel Strikes of Natural Disasters: In 1953, the situation was such that on one hand floodwaters were causing havoc, while on the other, drought persisted. North Bihar's rivers (Kosi, Kamla, Bagmati, Gandak) were changing course and flooding new areas.

- Relief Work and Administrative Challenge: Questions were constantly raised about the government's relief distribution system. Due to a shortage of boats and the slowness of officials, help did not reach affected people on time. The situation was most severe in Saharsa, Darbhanga, and Muzaffarpur districts.

• People's Demands and Struggles: People were not satisfied with just 'relief'; they demanded permanent 'means of livelihood'. Submerged agricultural land led to unemployment and hunger.

• Author's Perspective: Dinesh Kumar Mishra clearly shows how even after independence, the people of Bihar could not free themselves from the curse of floods and droughts. Through contemporary newspapers and Assembly debates, he shows how far the governance system was lagging in dealing with the disaster.

This is a document of the social and economic pain of Bihar, where the self-respect of common people wavered amidst the failures of nature and administration.

"1954: Vipattiyon ko jhelna Bihar ki pehchan ban chuka hai" (1954: Enduring calamities has become Bihar's identity):

• Bihar's Fate and the 1854 Flood: The chapter title makes it clear that by 1954, natural disasters like floods and droughts had become an integral part of Bihar's life. Elders and the government still recall the severe flood of 1954.

• Deception of Hathiya Nakshatra: The 1954 flood was severe, but an irony was that there was almost no rainfall in the Hathiya constellation that year. Consequently, the rabi crop was almost completely destroyed, creating a severe food crisis in early 1955.

- Whispers of the Kosi Project: There was much talk of building an 800-foot high dam at Barahkshetra in Nepal to free the region from the Kosi's devastation, but the pace of work on the ground was very slow. The devastation caused by the 1954 flood increased pressure on the government for Kosi control.

• Parallel Strikes of Flood and Drought: 1953 and 1954 were consecutive years of floods. Bihar's geography was such that while North Bihar's rivers wreaked havoc, irregular rainfall was destroying crops on the other side.

• Administrative Failure and People's Struggle: The author shows how the government machinery slowed down during disasters. Delays and corruption in relief distribution increased, rather than decreased, people's suffering.

• Importance of Historical Document: This chapter presents the real picture of 1954, where the people of Bihar fought floods with their might, but the governance system lagged in meeting their needs.

This chapter witnesses the painful time in Bihar in 1954, where the double blow of nature (flood and then drought) and government indifference made people's lives miserable.

"1955: Baadh ka pani un ilakon mein bhi pahuncha jahan vah pahle kabhi nahi gaya" (1955: Floodwater reached even those areas where it had never gone before):

• Unprecedented Flood: The 1955 flood was a tragedy in Bihar's history where water even reached areas that had never flooded before. This flood was so widespread that it proved all administration estimates wrong.

• Progress of Kosi Project: After the severe 1954 flood, work on the Kosi Project (embankment construction) began rapidly in 1955. Meanwhile, the Kosi changed its course, causing devastation in new areas.

• Impact of Hathiya Nakshatra: The author mentions that due to the lack of rainfall in the Hathiya constellation in 1954, the rabi crop was destroyed, causing a severe food crisis (famine-like situation) in early 1955.

• Relief and Administrative Challenge: The challenge for the government was the food shortage from the previous year's drought and the unprecedented 1955 flood that displaced millions. The shortage of boats and accessibility issues were major obstacles in relief distribution.

• Behavior of Rivers: Besides the Kosi, the Kamla, Bagmati, and Gandak rivers also displayed their fierce form. Floodwater spread was observed from May to November, delaying rabi sowing.

• People's Pain and Displacement: Through interviews with elders, this chapter shows how ancestral villages and homes were swallowed by river currents. Feelings of insecurity and helplessness were deep among the people.

This chapter is a historical document of the painful situation in Bihar in 1955, where nature's uncertainty and the administrative system's struggle are clearly visible.

The period from 1953 to 1955 in Bihar's modern history is a document of hydrological catastrophe and policy transition that permanently affected the state's geographical form and socio-economic structure. This period not only witnessed devastating floods, but the government decisions taken during this time—especially the construction of embankments on the Kosi and Gandak rivers—proved both a boon and a curse for Bihar's future. Through deep study of Dinesh Kumar Mishra's 'Pani Ka Shaap' and other official documents, it is clear that the debates in the Bihar Legislature during these three years, the struggles of the people, and the stories of administrative failure still resonate in the state's flood management policy.

1953: Footsteps of Catastrophe and Administrative Inertia

The year 1953 brought a dual challenge for Bihar. The state was trying to recover from the severe drought of 1950-51, but fate had something else in store. On January 8, 1953, a meeting of food ministers was held in Delhi, where Prime Minister Nehru called for self-reliance in food, but no expert had predicted that within a few months, the rivers of North Bihar would submerge the food reserves.

1953-54 Budget and Irrigation Schemes

On February 16, 1953, Finance Minister Anugrah Narayan Singh presented the budget in the Legislature. According to government data, Rs. 10,596,000 had been spent on relief work in the previous three years. The government's focus was on the 'Grow More Food' campaign, emphasizing tube wells and minor irrigation schemes. However, members like Murli Manohar Prasad warned in the Legislature that delays in the Gandak Project could ignite discontent in North Bihar.

| Relief Expenditure (1950-1953) | Expenditure (in Lakh Rupees) |

| : | : |

| Gratuitous Relief | 108.90 |

| Hard Manual Labor Schemes | 198.80 |

| Light Manual Labor Schemes | 45.60 |

| Taccavi Loans (Agricultural) | 687.20 |

| Total Expenditure | 1059.60 |

This table shows that a large portion of government funds was being spent on immediate relief for droughts and floods, leaving less money for long-term infrastructural development.

Regional Impact of the 1953 Flood

The rains starting in the last week of June 1953 continued until August, submerging North Bihar. The Kosi, Bagmati, Burhi Gandak, and Kamla rivers broke their banks and flooded villages.

• Saharsa and Kosi Region: By July 21, 1953, the Kosi had surrounded 600,000 people. Supaul, Nirmali, and Mahishi areas were cut off from the rest of the world. People were forced to live on machans and faced the terror of crocodiles in the water, as testified by Munner Yadav of Supaul.

- Muzaffarpur and Darbhanga: The Bagmati river's floods turned Sitamarhi town into an island. Boats plied on the town's roads, and the flood in the Lakhandei river cut off Muzaffarpur-Sitamarhi connectivity. According to Raghunath Ji of Pupri, although water came, it also brought silt, making crops better, but there was no scientific arrangement for drainage.

• Champaran Tragedy: The water level of the Sikrahna river reached 247.75 feet at the Chanpatia railway bridge on July 30, breaking all previous records. The lower parts of Motihari town were flooded, and even the municipality office was submerged.

• Saran's Catastrophe: The Ghaghra river's erosion caused 'Jaan Tola' village to be completely absorbed by the Ganga. The 'Naini Dam' built to protect Chapra town overflowed, causing havoc in the city.

1953 Legislative Discourse: North vs. South Bihar

The debate on floods in the Bihar Legislative Assembly on September 28 and 29, 1953, revealed the regional politics of the state. Girijanandan Singh accused the government of treating North Bihar like a stepchild. Karpoori Thakur strongly criticized the government's irrigation policy, stating that the government was only racing on paper while people were on the brink of starvation.

Specifically, the issue of increase in water rates was fiercely contested by opposition members. They argued that while the government tried to collect taxes when there was water, the administration was nowhere to be found during floods. Irrigation Minister Ramcharitra Singh argued that funds were needed to run the irrigation department, but members accused the department of widespread corruption preventing water from reaching fields.

1954: Devastating Floods and the Historic Turning Point of the Kosi Agreement

The year 1954 was a period in Bihar that was considered even more catastrophic than the 1934 earthquake. This year, all rivers of North Bihar flooded simultaneously, crippling the state's economy.

Kosi Agreement (April 25, 1954)

After the 1953 flood, Prime Minister Nehru visited Saharsa and resolved to 'tame' the Kosi. Prior to this, there was talk of an 800-foot high dam at Barahkshetra, but on the advice of the expert committee (KL Rao and Kanwar Sain), the option of constructing embankments was chosen. On April 25, 1954, the Kosi Agreement was signed between India and Nepal in Kathmandu, paving the way for the construction of the Kosi Barrage and embankments.

| Key Components of Kosi Project | Details |

| : | : |

| Barrage Location | Bhimnagar (Nepal) |

| Embankment Length | Approximately 150 km (both sides) |

| Estimated Cost | Rs. 37.5 crore |

| Main Benefit | Protection of 2.1 lakh hectares of land |

However, political discontent arose in Nepal after this agreement, with the opposition accusing the government of selling the Kosi.

Severity of the 1954 Flood

In July 1954, the Gandak river carried over 700,000 cusecs of water, the highest flow since 1883. On July 21, the Kosi also broke all previous records. An area of 4,000 square miles in Muzaffarpur, Darbhanga, Saharsa, and Purnia was submerged.

• Muzaffarpur Devastation: On August 1, 1954, the Burhi Gandak's water entered Muzaffarpur town. In Chandwara and Golaghat areas, there was up to 6 feet of water in people's homes.

• Heart-Wrenching Situation in Saharsa: Lahtan Choudhary told the Assembly that 13 out of 16 police stations in Saharsa were submerged. Nirmali town had 5 feet of water, and people had taken refuge with their livestock on the railway line.

• Oblivion of Purnia: Kamaldeo Narayan Singh complained that newspapers were ignoring the flood in Purnia, where 1.5 million people were affected.

1954 Legislative Discourse: Irony of Famine and Drought

On September 1, 1954, the government admitted in the Legislature that damage exceeded Rs. 5 billion. But in a strange irony, while North Bihar was drowning in floods, reports of drought started coming from South Bihar (Patna, Gaya, Shahabad) on September 7.

In the Assembly, Sardar Harihar Singh mocked the government's 'expert phobia'. He said that while fields were drying up, government experts were advising people to transplant paddy. Due to the drought, 75 percent of the aghani paddy was scorched, creating a famine-like situation in the state.

1955: Embankment Construction and the Politics of Shramdan

The year 1955 was the year of practical implementation in Bihar's flood control direction. Construction of the Kosi embankment began in January 1955.

### Bharat Sevak Samaj and Shramdan

The 'Bharat Sevak Samaj' (BSS) was involved in the Kosi embankment construction to ensure public participation. However, politics and corruption also crept in. Opposition leaders alleged that BSS funds were not audited, and contracts were awarded only to people aligned with the ruling party. BSS argued that they were doing work at a lower cost through village panchayats.

### Seasonal Uncertainty of 1955

Untimely rainfall in February 1955 caused heavy damage to the rabi crop. This was the third blow to farmers after the floods and droughts of the previous two years. During the Legislative debate, Ramesh Jha said that laborers working on the stretch from Nirmali to Mahadevmadh were not getting paid on time, and the attitude of engineers was dictatorial.

### Neglect of the Gandak Project

During 1955 as well, legislators from North Bihar kept demanding the Gandak Project. Sukhdev Narayan Mahtha alleged that the government was treating the Gandak like a stepmother, diverting its funds to the Kosi, while the Gandak Project could irrigate more area at lower cost.

### Long-Term Impact of 1953-55 Floods and Policy Analysis

This three-year period brought a fundamental change in Bihar's flood management policy. The state adopted the 'embankment construction' model, the consequences of which are still debated.

### Failure of Embankments and Waterlogging

In 1954, Bihar had only 160 km of embankments, but by 2020, this had increased to over 3,700 km. The irony is that when embankments were less, 2.5 million hectares were flood-affected, but after embankments increased, this area increased to 7.3 million hectares. Embankments trap the silt, raising the riverbed and making it higher than the surrounding land, causing greater devastation when they breach.

### Displacement and Rehabilitation Problems

During the Kosi embankment construction, 304 villages got trapped inside. The issue of their displacement was raised during the 1954 flood, but their rehabilitation remains incomplete even today. For those inside the embankments, the flood is an annual tragedy that began with these decisions of 1953-55.

Governance and Legislative Contradictions

Assembly debates reveal that while public representatives favored reviving local irrigation systems (ahar, pyne, ponds), the government was chasing 'large engineering projects'. Corruption and the politics of relief have become an integral part of Bihar's flood story from that time to today.

Conclusion: Lessons from History and Future Challenges

The floods of 1953-55 in Bihar were not just a natural disaster, but a document of administrative failure, political opportunism, and lack of scientific foresight. From Prime Minister Nehru's visit to the Kosi Agreement, immediate relief was prioritized, but long-term ecological balance was ignored. Floods remain a fate for Bihar even today, but the history of 1953-55 warns us that rivers cannot be conquered by merely 'imprisoning' them in embankments. The traditional knowledge of 'living with the river' needs to be coordinated with modern engineering. The legislative debates of this period teach us that as long as local voices are not given a place in policy-making, the 'curse' of floods will continue to haunt Bihar.

When we look at the data of 1953-55 today, it is clear that Bihar's water politics is the same, only the scale of destruction has increased. The Rs. 5 billion loss of 1954 has now reached billions. This research report confirms that the solution to Bihar's floods lies not just in embankments but in integrated river basin management and social justice.

The 1950s are etched in Bihar's geographical and social history as a period where nature displayed its most ferocious and unpredictable form. This report presents a deep and detailed analysis of the devastating floods in Bihar, especially North Bihar, between 1953 and 1955, the drought in South Bihar, the political discourse, and the changing form of water management policy. 73.06 percent of Bihar's geographical area is flood-prone, with 76 percent of North

Bihar's population constantly under the shadow of flood devastation. North Bihar's rivers, like Kosi, Gandak, Burhi Gandak, Bagmati, Kamla Balan, and Mahananda, originate from the Himalayan region of Nepal. These rivers bring huge amounts of silt and water and deposit them in Bihar's flat plains, causing constant changes in the geographical landscape. The early 1950s began with severe drought, but the period from 1953 to 1955 is marked in history for the deluge of floods and the subsequent drought.

## 1953 Deluge: From Drought to Flood

The years 1950 and 1951 were years of famine and drought in Bihar, with severe food shortages. Some signs of improvement were seen in 1952, but in 1953, the situation reversed completely. On January 8, 1953, a conference of food and supply ministers from all 25 states was held in Delhi to discuss hoarding, grain procurement, and reducing dependence on foreign grain. Prime Minister Pandit Nehru called for self-reliance in the food sector, but Bihar's fate had something else written.

The 1953 flood was not an ordinary flood; it was termed a 'deluge'. This flood gave a clear message to officials that merely distributing immediate 'relief' was not enough; a long-term plan was needed. In the state government's budget speech (1953-54), Finance Minister Anugrah Narayan Singh presented the expenditure on famine and flood relief, giving an idea of the state's financial burden.

## Legislative Discourse and Gandak-Kosi Conflict

The 1953 session of the Bihar Legislative Assembly saw extensive debate on floods and irrigation. The center of this debate was the future of the Gandak and Kosi projects. Governor R.R. Diwakar, in his address on January 28, 1953, said that the paddy crop in the state was good, but the lack of irrigation remained a major challenge.

## Neglect of Gandak Project and Forebodings of Revolt

Mahamaya Prasad Singh raised the question of the Gandak Project, stating that the population of 3 million in a district like Chapra was dying of hunger. The Gandak scheme could provide irrigation to parts of Muzaffarpur, Motihari, Chapra, and Darbhanga, but it was being delayed due to pressure from the

central government. Murli Manohar Prasad warned that the Gandak Project could irrigate 2.8 million acres at a cost of Rs. 27 crore, while even large projects like Bhakra-Nangal combined could not provide so much irrigation. He cautioned that further delay in this scheme could lead to a revolt against the state government in North Bihar.

### Karpoori Thakur's Farmer Sensitivity

MLA Karpoori Thakur brought the plight of farmers from the Samastipur and Warisnagar areas to the fore. He said that in 1952, the dardha bandh and chamarbandha breached, destroying the paddy crop. Farmers were hoping for the rabi crop, but heavy hailstorms in January 1953 destroyed the arhar, tobacco, and rabi saplings. Later, in the August 1954 flood, the northern part of Samastipur town saw 62 cm of water accumulation, mainly due to the breach of the Soropatti bandh. Karpoori Thakur argued that the government is not a commercial institution; its purpose should be public service, and increasing canal rates was not fair.

### 'Expert Phobia' and Administrative Inertia

Champaran's MLA Harivansh Sahay discussed 'Expert Phobia' (fear of experts). He argued that due to engineers' technical mistakes, farmers in the Bahadurpur-Kesaria chaurs were suffering losses instead of receiving irrigation benefits. Where regulators were needed to drain water, no arrangements were made, and where embankments were not needed, they were built. Ram Sewak Sharan gave the example of wasteful expenditure on the Lakhandei river in Muzaffarpur, where after spending Rs. 950,000, no benefit accrued to farmers.

### District-wise Flood Report 1953

The monsoon of 1953 became active in the last week of June and altered the entire North Bihar landscape.

### Munger, Begusarai, and Khagaria

According to the Munger Gazetteer (1960), the Ganga, Kosi, Burhi Gandak, and Bagmati caused simultaneous destruction. In Begusarai sub-division, the Burhi Gandak rose 3 feet above its highest level. The breach of the Sikraula-Thathai embankment submerged dozens of villages. In Khagaria, the Kosi's

water afflicted 70,000 people in the Parbatta, Gogri, and Chautham thanas. Water spread 3 to 7 feet, destroying the bhadai and aghani crops.

### Purnia and Mahananda Basin

According to the Purnia Gazetteer (1963), all major North Bihar rivers were in spate in 1953. Ganga's water breached the embankments between Kadha Gola and Bhavanipur. The old Kosi channel 'Kari Kosi' also became active. The Mahananda, Dauk, and Parman rivers remained within their banks, but the situation could have become more serious combined with the Kosi and Ganga.

### Champaran and Gandak's Ferocity

In Champaran, all the small and large rivers originating from Nepal flooded simultaneously between July 24-27, 1953. The Sikrahna river flowed 1.75 feet above its highest level. The lower part of Motihari town was submerged, and water reached the municipality. A breach occurred at mile 52/53 of the Champaran embankment near Barharwa village, allowing Gandak's water to enter the countryside.

### Muzaffarpur and Bagmati's Wrath

Heavy rainfall in the Bagmati's Nepal catchment caused devastation in the Shivhar and Belasand areas of Muzaffarpur. Small streams like Sugiya-Pardesiya also became active, causing severe damage in the Minapur thana. The uneven riverbed caused by the 1934 earthquake also hindered drainage. The Sitamarhi-Muzaffarpur road was damaged at several places.

### Saharsa and Kosi Displacement

The Kosi river made its presence felt in Saharsa and the eastern part of Darbhanga in late June 1953. Areas like Supaul, Mahishi, and Nirmali bore the first brunt. Within a week, 1 million people were crying for help. Witnessing the severity of this flood, Prime Minister Nehru had to visit Saharsa, laying the foundation for the Kosi Project.

### 1954 Mahapralay (Great Deluge): A New Record of Destruction

The year 1954 brought an unprecedented calamity for Bihar. This flood was considered more devastating than the 1934 earthquake. 9,608 square miles of North Bihar (44.5% of its total area) were submerged.

Journey from Kosi High Dam to Embankment Policy

Initially, to protect from Kosi floods, a 700-foot high concrete dam at Barahkshetra in Nepal was proposed. However, the Majumdar Committee in 1951 deemed it economically and technically impractical due to its cost of Rs. 1.77 billion. After the 1953 deluge, the Government of India decided on a 'temporary and quick solution' of building a 150 km long embankment, estimated to cost only Rs. 37.5 crore. The Lok Sabha approved the scheme in December 1953, and on January 14, 1955, Chief Minister Shri Krishna Sinha laid its foundation in Nirmali (Saharsa).

Statistical Impact of the 1954 Flood

In August 1954, all North Bihar rivers—Gandak, Kosi, Bagmati, Kamla—were simultaneously at their highest levels. The Gandak carried over 700,000 cusecs, and the Kosi over 850,000 cusecs of water.

| Table: Damage from Floods by September 1, 1954 (North Bihar) | Statistical Data |
|---|---|
| Total Geographical Area | 21,445 sq miles |
| Flood Affected Area | 9,608 sq miles (44.5%) |
| Total Affected Population | 7.065 million (38.4%) |
| Number of Affected Villages | 8,119 |
| Destroyed Crop Area | 4.676 million acres |
| Destroyed Houses | 74,917 |
| Human Deaths | 63 |
| Livestock Deaths | 1,173 |

(Source: Report of Chief Engineer M.P. Mathrani, 1955)

Impact of Drought and Failure of 'Hathiya' Nakshatra

A striking irony was that while North Bihar was struggling with water, South Bihar and Chotanagpur were suffering from drought. In September 1954, the Assembly debated the lack of rainfall.

### Famine Situation in South Bihar

Revenue Minister Krishna Ballabh Sahay admitted that rainfall was very low in Gaya, Shahabad, and Patna districts. Due to the lack of rain in the Hathiya constellation, 75-80 percent of the aghani paddy crop was destroyed. Sardar Harihar Singh said, 'Utra (Hathiya) me mat ropinh bhaiya, teen dhan me terah paiya' (Don't transplant after Hathiya, brother, 13 measures for 3 of paddy) – meaning farming after the time is futile. Sukra Oraon said that people were migrating to tea gardens in Bengal and Assam to alleviate hunger.

### Failure of 'Hathiya' and Rabi Crisis

In October 1954, Searchlight wrote that the failure of 'Hathiya' left no moisture in the ground for the rabi crop. Distress prevailed in Hisua and Fatehpur police stations in Gaya. The government allocated Rs. 1.1 million for relief work, but it was negligible compared to the need.

### Social and Economic Impact: Voices from Oral History

The impact of floods and droughts was not limited to government files; it had a deep social impact that can be understood through oral history.

### Memories of Munner Yadav (Saharsa)

84-year-old Munner Yadav of Supaul says that before the embankment was built, the Kosi was in its original form. At that time, tigers lived in the forests and crocodiles in the river. After the embankment, the river became shallow, and due to sand accumulation, local paddy varieties (Satraja, Matiya, Gola, Tanjali) have disappeared. Farmers are now forced to grow maize, which is destroyed by wild boars.

### Memories of Raghunath Ji and Pupri (Sitamarhi)

79-year-old Raghunath Ji of Pupri, recalling the 1953 flood, says that boats plied at the Azad Chowk in Pupri. At that time, people considered floodwater a

boon because the silt increased field fertility. Without embankments, water spread, keeping the level low, and water receded within 2-3 days. Now, due to embankments, water stagnation has increased.

### Migration and Social Disintegration

After the 1954 flood and drought, the migration of laborers from Bihar towards 'Bengal' (east) took the form of mass displacement. People would hang from the roofs and footboards of trains seeking livelihood. Siyaram Yadav (former MLA) says people would migrate to Calcutta and often not return for years, leading to family discord and the breakdown of social relations.

### Administrative Corruption and Paradox of Relief

Corruption in relief work and administrative inertia was a major issue. Members of the Legislative Assembly alleged that contractors were selling cement and iron.

• Chamarbandha Dam Scandal: Rs. 41,000 was spent on repairing this dam, but the contractor took soil from old pits and spread it on the dam, pocketing all the money. Consequently, the bridge built on the dam collapsed.

• Bias in Relief Distribution: Saharsa MLA Ramesh Jha said that where 80,000 people were affected, only 28,000 yards of cloth were being distributed. Rotten grain was being distributed as relief.

• Dependency vs. Self-Respect: Ram Binod Singh said that distributing relief was demoralizing people. Both big and small were standing in queues for relief, eroding the moral fabric of society.

### Role of National Leadership and 'Chinese Method'

Witnessing the devastation of floods, national leaders visited Bihar.

### Jawaharlal Nehru

Pandit Nehru conducted aerial surveys of Bihar in 1953 and 1954. On October 30, 1953, he flew over the Ganga, Gandak, and Kosi areas. Nehru's thought was to adopt the 'Chinese Way' for flood control, which involved mass labor mobilization. He said that digging a well after a fire is not good; preparation should be done beforehand.

Rajendra Prasad and Jagjivan Ram

President Rajendra Prasad came to Bihar in October 1954. He appealed to the public for restraint and motivated them to lend a hand in flood protection work. Jagjivan Ram stated in Patna on August 11, 1954, that the damage in 1954 was even greater than the 1934 earthquake.

Gandak and Burhi Gandak: A Painful Chapter

The Gandak river forms the boundary between Champaran and Saran. In 1953, the Champaran embankment on the Gandak had several gaps, allowing water to escape and sweep away entire villages. Several kilometers of the Tirhut embankment were eroded. The Burhi Gandak flooded Samastipur town, where no such flood had occurred in the last 50 years.

Conclusion: Policy Failure and Future Challenges

The period 1953-1955 serves as a harsh lesson in Bihar's water history. Analysis of this period yields several important conclusions:

- Irony of Embankments: Building embankments did not stop floods; instead, the flood-affected area expanded. In 1954, when there were 160 km of embankments, the flood-affected area was 2.5 million hectares. Today, with over 3,700 km of embankments, it is over 7 million hectares. Embankments straitjacket the river, causing silt to accumulate and the riverbed to rise.

• Ecological and Social Justice: Embankments have blocked natural drainage, creating a permanent problem of waterlogging in chaur areas. Communities like Musahars and Mallahs, already on the margins, are the worst affected.

• Political-Administrative Nexus: Floods and droughts have become an 'industry' in Bihar, where the nexus of leaders, engineers, and contractors exploits public funds.

• Neglect of Local Knowledge: The voices of experienced people like Munner Yadav and Raghunath Ji make it clear that flood used to be a 'blessing' but is now a 'curse' because modern engineering failed to understand local geography.

For Bihar, merely damming water is not enough; the art of living with floods and a policy of equitable water distribution are needed. The deluge of the 1950s

still resides in the eyes of Bihar's farmers, and understanding and learning from it is essential for the future.

"1956: Rabi ki fasal chait baishakh ke pahle to hogi hi nahi tab tak kya?" (1956: The rabi crop won't be ready until Chait-Baishakh, what till then?):

• Parallel Strikes of Flood and Drought: 1956 was a year where both flood and drought occurred simultaneously in Bihar. While some parts of the state were devastated by floods, other parts were reeling from drought.

• Crop Uncertainty and Fear of Famine: According to the chapter title, the kharif crop was destroyed by floods, and people worried how they would survive until the rabi crop, which wouldn't be ready until Chait-Baishakh. The availability of food was extremely precarious.

- Impact of the Kosi Embankment: By 1956, work on the Kosi Project (embankment construction) had progressed significantly. However, for people trapped inside the embankments, this turned into a new kind of tragedy. While those outside felt protected, those inside saw their homes and fields merging into the river currents.

• Waterlogging Problem: After the construction of embankments on the Kosi and other rivers, severe waterlogging occurred in areas where it had never happened before. The Water Resources Department also admitted that the flood-prone area had increased two-and-a-half to three times since independence.

• Relief and Administrative Failure: The government claimed to be providing relief, but the situation on the ground was dire. People complained that administrative help was not reaching them on time, and corruption was a major obstacle.

• People's Pain and Struggle: Through interviews with elders, the author shows how people were being evicted from their heritage and means of livelihood. People needed 'work and grain' more than 'relief'.

This chapter depicts the transitional period in Bihar in 1956, where large engineering projects (embankments) were built, but they could not free the common people from the curse of floods and droughts, creating new problems instead.

The year 1956 is marked as a transitional period in Bihar's geographical and hydrological map, where a severe conflict was witnessed between the engineering legacy of the colonial period and the aspirations of independent India's reconstruction. This report presents a detailed and serious analysis of the flood and drought devastation in Bihar's northern and southern regions, the technical management of the Kosi project, and the contemporary legislative discourse. In 1956, Bihar was not just a victim of natural disaster, but this year was also a witness to flawed technical decisions, administrative laxity, and the indomitable spirit of the common people.

## Historical and Legislative Background of 1956

The start of 1956 in Bihar's water-political history was marked by ideological turmoil. After the devastation of the 1955 flood, the 1956 Assembly session began earlier than usual on January 31. Then Governor R.R. Diwakar, in his address, considered the state's agricultural progress entirely dependent on irrigation development. The Governor's speech mentioned the progress of the Kosi and Triveni canal schemes and the installation of 950 tube wells, but the ground reality was different. Due to the failure of rainfall in the Hathiya constellation in 1955, drought conditions arose in Bhagalpur, Munger, Gaya, and Shahabad districts in South Bihar, casting a shadow over the 1956 rabi crop.

A major controversy arose at the legislative level over not extending the service of the Chief Engineer of the Irrigation Department, Deshraj Mehta. Despite Mehta's experience and qualifications at 55, the decision not to extend his service was criticized by opposition and some ruling party members. Irrigation Minister Ramcharitra Singh dismissed it as a collective decision of the cabinet, but this brought the discourse of technical expertise versus administrative rigidity to the fore. Meanwhile, on February 26, 1956, President Dr. Rajendra Prasad laid the foundation stone for the first bridge over the Ganga between Mokama and Barauni, a significant milestone for connecting North and South Bihar.

## Kosi Project: Engineering Ambition and Reality

The Kosi Project, called 'Bihar's Sorrow', saw rapid construction of embankments in 1955-56 after the 1954 agreement. In 1956, the administrative

framework of the Kosi Project was entrusted to a separate unit of the Irrigation Department called the 'River Valley Project'.

### Embankment Construction and Public Participation

A new experiment of 'public participation' was carried out in the Kosi embankment construction through the 'Bharat Sevak Samaj' (BSS). The Governor's speech highly praised it, but on the actual work sites, shortage of laborers and payment problems persisted. The target by June 1956 was to complete 16 miles of the right embankment and 14 miles of the left embankment in Nepal. The main objective of this engineering effort was to stabilize the river's course, but technical experts were also warning about the riverbed rising due to silt accumulation.

### Technical Conflict: High Dam vs. Embankment

Initially, a large high dam at 'Barahkshetra' in Nepal, three times taller than the Qutub Minar, was considered to solve the Kosi problem. However, due to high cost, seismic risk, and lack of technical expertise, that plan was postponed, and the cheaper option of embankments was chosen. According to Dinesh Kumar Mishra's analysis, this decision was driven by 'extra-technical' considerations, prioritizing immediate political gain over long-term hydrological consequences.

### Regional Flood and Drought Devastation (1956)

The year 1956 was a peculiar one for Bihar, with untimely floods in May-June and severe drought in August, followed again by devastating floods in September.

### Darbhanga District: Caught in the Flood-Drought Mill

In Darbhanga district, the waters of the Kosi, Kamla, Bhutahi Balan, and Bagmati started wreaking havoc from early June. Water rose so rapidly that many villages in Phoolparas, Biraul, Madhepur, and Singhia thanas turned into islands. Water levels reached up to 5 feet in some places. The Bhutahi Balan's water flowed 2 feet above the Nirmali railway bridge, disrupting rail services.

The floodwaters receded in July, but by August, the district came under drought. Lack of rainfall caused maize and paddy saplings to dry up. When MP Lalit Narayan Mishra toured the area, he noted that people in Darbhanga, who once had 8-10 grain storage bins at their doorsteps, were now yearning for charity.

### Saharsa: 'Prisoners' of the Embankment

Saharsa district was the main center of the Kosi. In 1956, the sudden rise in Kosi water entered through the 'Fulkaha Gap' of the under-construction eastern embankment in Supaul sub-division. 102-year-old Gulat Prasad Yadav described this event. He said the river water came out through the gap between 12-1 AM, causing a stampede. People took refuge on the embankment itself for 6 months to save their lives. Having nothing to wear or cover with, they made mats from pater.

### Munger and Begusarai: Ganga Erosion and Mirzapur Incident

The erosion of the Ganga river was very severe in 1956 in the Begusarai sub-division of Munger district. Madhurapur village, famous for its pucca houses and orchards, lost 300 bighas of land and 150 houses to the river. In September, the rising level of the Burhi Gandak breached the embankment near Mirzapur village on the night of September 23.

94-year-old Rajendra Rai recalls that the embankment was new and its compaction was not done. The breach diverted water towards 'Kabir Jheel', submerging many villages in the Cheria Bariarpur, Khodawandpur blocks. When Chief Minister Dr. Shri Krishna Sinha visited, he asked the engineer if Lord Ram could build a bridge over the sea, why couldn't he fill this gap?

### Bhagalpur: Dance of the Chandan and Gerua

In Bhagalpur district, besides the Kosi and Ganga, the Chandan and Gerua rivers also caused devastation. In June, 3,000 acres of land in 20 villages of Sonhaula thana were submerged. The Chandan river's embankment in the Sadar sub-division broke several times, destroying crops and causing a severe shortage of cattle fodder.

Severity of Drought: August 1956

After the severe deluge of floods, 13 out of 17 districts of Bihar came under drought in August 1956. Revenue Minister Krishna Ballabh Sahay admitted that the situation was most critical in Muzaffarpur, Darbhanga, Patna, Gaya, and Shahabad.

• Patna and Gaya: There was drought in the Nalanda-Rajgir area for the past 3 months. Ahar-pyne systems in Gaya district dried up, preventing paddy transplantation.

• Migration of Laborers: The drought deprived landless laborers of employment. Groups of laborers were forced to migrate towards Bengal and Assam.

• Water Conflict: News of clashes between two groups for irrigation water was also raised in the Legislative Assembly.

Legislative Debate: The Great Clash of September 1956

On September 5, 1956, Revenue Minister Krishna Ballabh Sahay presented a government statement on flood and drought in the Legislative Assembly. He claimed the government was providing adequate relief, but opposition members surrounded the government.

Strong Attacks by Opposition Members

• Chandrashekhar Singh (Begusarai): Called the government's report an "aerial report of an aerial survey." He criticized the corruption in tube well construction, saying engineers stole cement and made sand drains that broke as soon as water came.

• Narendra Nath Das (Darbhanga): Called the Irrigation Department's 'Lakhandei' and 'Chanour' drainage schemes a "total failure." He said sluice gates were built above the water level, preventing water from draining.

• Guptnath Singh (Shahabad): Said no permanent effort was being made to stop floods. He suggested the government should stockpile animal fodder.

• Ram Binod Singh (Saran): Complained that Saran district was surrounded by the Ganga, Gandak, and Saryu, but the government's report did not even mention Saran.

### Irrigation Minister Ramcharitra Singh's Argument

Irrigation Minister Ramcharitra Singh tried to defend his department by calling embankment breaches 'God's will'. When Triveni Kumar questioned the breach of the Parbatta embankment, the Minister replied, "When a flood comes, insects die and the crop becomes good; your prayers were heard by Mother Ganga." This irresponsible statement reflects the insensitivity of the then administration.

### Technical Failure and Lessons for the Future

Data and events from 1956 make it clear that the engineering model for flood control in Bihar had serious flaws.

### Failure of Sluice Gates

The sluice gates installed in the embankments failed in their purpose. MLA Naval Kishore Singh said these gates neither drained water nor provided irrigation water to fields. The main reasons were design flaws and lack of maintenance.

### Siltation and Bed Rising

When rivers like the Kosi, which bring vast amounts of silt from the Himalayas, are confined within embankments, their beds start rising. In 1956 itself, it was observed that the Kosi's water was flowing close to the under-construction embankment. Silt accumulation reduced the river's depth and its capacity to carry floodwater.

### Economic and Social Displacement

The 1956 flood and drought destroyed the purchasing power of rural Bihar. When the government provided relief, it attempted to recover it as malguzari, causing great resentment among farmers.

### Conclusion

The 1956 water disaster in Bihar was not just a natural event, but a complex mixture of man-made engineering structures and administrative insensitivity. While on one hand, the construction of the Kosi embankment claimed to protect millions, on the other, it imprisoned about 200,000 people between the river

currents. The issues of corruption, technical failure, and discrimination in relief distribution raised in the legislative debates are just as relevant in Bihar's water politics today.

Dinesh Kumar Mishra's 'Pani Ka Shaap' and other research materials prove that if we do not understand the natural behavior of rivers and prioritize local knowledge (ahar, pyne, chaurs), engineering structures will remain 'silt-laden time bombs'. The lesson of 1956 is that flood management is possible not just through concrete and earthen structures, but through public participation and ecological balance.

The role of water in Bihar's geographical and social history has been dialectical. On one hand, the rivers here have been the mothers of civilization; on the other, they have also become synonymous with catastrophe. Dinesh Kumar Mishra's timeless work 'Pani Ka Shaap: Bihar Mein Baadh-Sukhad' is not just a book, but an authentic historical document of the interrelation between natural disasters, society, and governance in Bihar from 1947 to 1956. Based on the said work, this report presents a detailed and serious analysis of Bihar's water management problems, the historical perspective of floods and droughts, and the new crises arising from technical interventions.

Famine and Flood Disasters in Bihar Before Independence

In the initial chapters, the author presents a detailed chronology of famines and floods in Bihar. The 19th century witnessed three severe famines in Bihar: 1865-66, 1873-74, and 1896-97. The main reasons behind these famines were the uncertainty of rainfall and the failure of the 'Hathiya' constellation to bring rain.

| Major Famine Years in Bihar Before Independence | Affected Areas |

| : | : |

| 1865-66 | Champaran, Tirhut, Bhagalpur, Saran, Shahabad, Gaya, Munger |

| 1873-74 | Shahabad, Saran, Darbhanga, Muzaffarpur, Champaran, Gaya |

| 1896-97 | Saran, Champaran, Muzaffarpur, Darbhanga, Bhagalpur |

Even in the 20th century before independence, the food situation was abnormal. During World War II (1939-1945), large quantities of grain were sent from Bihar to England and allied nations, the consequence of which was seen in the Bengal Famine of 1943, which also cast its shadow on Bihar.

Bihar's situation regarding floods has also always been dire. Rivers like the Kosi, Kamla, Gandak, Ganga, Bagmati, and Mahananda keep changing their course. The Kosi river, in particular, is called 'Bihar's Sorrow' due to its destructive nature.

| Major Rivers and Historical Flood Years | Year |

| : | : |

| Kosi | 1893, 1902, 1906, 1926-43 (every year) |

| Bagmati | 1785, 1867, 1893, 1902, 1910, 1916-19 |

| Ganga | 1901, 1902, 1913, 1917, 1923, 1934 |

1946: Last Major Flood of British Rule and the Gaya Deluge

Exactly one year before independence in 1947, an unprecedented flood occurred in Gaya district, Bihar. This flood was caused by the rising of the Phalgu river, with water entering the city's Collectorate and Treasury. The horror of this flood is mirrored in the words of 92-year-old priest Kritinath Garda: "The Pitri Paksha fair was going on, and about one lakh pilgrims were in Gaya. At night, the Phalgu river broke its banks and started flowing. People tried to save their lives by climbing onto roofs, but many roofs were swept away." In this flood, over 100 people drowned, and thousands of cattle perished. This event symbolized the failure of British rule, where there was no system for flood warnings.

1947: Joy of Independence and Fear of Famine

India became independent on August 15, 1947, but for Bihar, this time was more challenging than joyous. The state's economy was stable, the population had grown to 38 million, and there was a severe food shortage. Cholera struck almost every year from 1943 to 1947. While the price of rice was Rs. 5-9 per man in 1941, it reached Rs. 23 per man by 1947.

### 'Grow More Food' and Grain Procurement

To tackle the food crisis, the government intensified the 'Grow More Food' campaign. Dr. Rajendra Prasad, who was then Food Minister in the interim government, toured Bihar and appealed to farmers to give their 'surplus' grain to the government. The government set a target of procuring 1.5 crore man of paddy to curb black marketing.

### Nirmali Kosi Conference (1947)

To escape the Kosi river's devastation, a large conference was held in Nirmali (Supaul) on April 5-6, 1947. A proposal was made to build an 800-foot high concrete dam at Barahkshetra in Nepal. The conference was attended by Dr. Rajendra Prasad, Prime Minister Shri Krishna Sinha, and American expert Dr. J.L. Savage. It was announced that this would generate 3300 MW of electricity and secure 5.28 lakh acres of land. However, it is a great irony that this plan remained confined to files for decades.

### 1948: First Major Flood of Independent India and Destruction in Saran

The 1948 flood was the first major trial for Bihar in independent India. This flood wreaked havoc mainly in Saran, Muzaffarpur, Darbhanga, Saharsa, and Shahabad districts.

### Devastation in Saran District

Saran has the confluence of the Ganga, Ghaghra, and Gandak. In August 1948, the Naini Dam and Kaudimal Dam broke, submerging over 1000 villages. The northern part of Chapra town and the area south of the railway line were completely flooded. 89-year-old Udit Rai of Sitab Diyara village says, "The village kept eroding until it was destroyed in 1976, but the 1948 flood was such that the entire village was displaced to Revelganj by boat."

| 1948 Flood Damage (Saran Sadar) | Details |
| --- | --- |
| Affected Villages | Over 1000 |
| Completely Submerged Villages | 700 |

| Destroyed Houses | 25,000 |

| Destroyed Bhadai Crop | 50,000 acres |

Saharsa and Kosi-Tilave Impact

In Saharsa and Supaul, floods arrived in late June. The combined fury of the Tilave and Kosi rivers cut off connectivity between Madhepura and Saharsa. People built bamboo machans to keep their families and livestock.

1949: From Relief to Livelihood

In 1949, floods arrived early, in the second week of June. In this chapter, Dinesh Kumar Mishra raises a serious question: "There are many places in the Kosi region that remain submerged all year... For those living in such areas, what is needed is not relief but means of livelihood."

That year, there was a demand in the Assembly for the formation of a Kosi department. Harinath Mishra proposed that revenue be remitted for the Kosi-affected area and health centers opened there. However, Irrigation Minister Ramcharitra Singh argued that preventing floods was beyond human control, and the government could only help as best as it could.

According to the memoirs of Kunal Krishna Mandal of Ranipatti in Madhepura, the Tilave river washed away his mansion-like house in 1949, after which his family started living in a hut on higher ground.

1950-1952: Cycle of Drought and Food Crisis in Mithila

While North Bihar was struggling with floods, a large part of Bihar fell into severe drought from 1950 to 1952. Especially in Gaya, Shahabad, and the Mithila region (Darbhanga, Muzaffarpur), the failure of the Hathiya constellation rains destroyed the paddy crop.

By 1951, the situation had become so dire that Bihar had to import grain from America. People said, "Don't give messages of sympathy, give us grain." The government admitted that central financial assistance was low, causing delays in the review of the Gandak and Kosi projects.

### 1953-1954: Flood Recurrence and 'Technical Exorcism' of Embankments

The 1954 flood is a timeless catastrophe in Bihar's history. That year, the Kosi changed its course so drastically that water entered areas it had never reached before.

### Embankments vs. Natural Flow

Author Dinesh Kumar Mishra criticizes the policy of flood control through embankments. He calls it 'Technical Exorcism'. Mishra ji's arguments are:

• Silt Problem: When the river is confined within embankments, its silt accumulates in the bed, raising the river's surface.

• Obstruction of Drainage: Embankments block the mouths of tributaries, causing waterlogging outside the dam.

• False Sense of Security: Embankments create a false sense of security, but when they break, the devastation is manifold greater.

### 1955-1956: Floods in New Areas and Rabi Crop Crisis

In 1955, floodwater reached areas that had never flooded before. The year 1956 was such that flood and drought ran parallel. Due to the lack of rainfall in the Hathiya constellation, the rabi crop (wheat, pulses) also came under crisis. By early 1957, Bihar's food situation had become extremely alarming.

### Technical and Behavioral Observation of Rivers

The book provides a detailed analysis of the behavior of major rivers in Bihar:

### Kosi (River Course Change and Silt)

The Kosi is one of the world's most silt-laden rivers. After descending from the Himalayas, it deposits huge amounts of sand and soil in the plains. After embankments were built, the land inside the Kosi became higher, causing the surrounding villages to become lower and perpetually waterlogged.

### Kamla and Jivach (Fertility of Mithila)

The Kamla river was known for its fertile silt. However, dam construction north of Jaynagar has obstructed its natural flow. The dam built to protect Madhubani town has often been a cause of failure.

Bagmati (Meandering Flow)

The Bagmati's course is highly meandering. When it floods, water stays in chaurs for many days.

Gandak (Tirhut and Saran Embankments)

The left (Tirhut) and right (Saran) embankments of the Gandak have been disputed since British times. The 1949 breach at Matiyari proved that embankments can never be 'impenetrable'.

Irony of Governance and Corruption

Dinesh Kumar Mishra strongly criticizes the 'politician-engineer-contractor' nexus pervasive in embankment construction. A 1990s figure highlights the seriousness of Mishra ji's research:

| Financial Discrepancy in Irrigation Department (1991-96) | Amount (in Crore Rupees) |

| : | : |

| Revenue Collection | 39 |

| Department's Own Maintenance Expenditure | 77.21 |

| Canal Maintenance Expenditure | 0 |

| Expenditure on Engineers' Salaries/Allowances | 4,297.95 |

This data proves that the system is more focused on sustaining itself than on protecting the public from disasters. The department's library was submerged in the 1975 flood, destroying old documents.

Conclusion and Future Path: Liberation from 'Pani Ka Shaap'

Dinesh Kumar Mishra's research narrative concludes that the concept of flood 'control' is flawed. The practice of 'living with floods' must be revived.

1. Restoration of Natural Flow: Obstructions (roads, railway dams) in the rivers' natural paths should be removed, and more bridges built to allow water to flow smoothly.

2. Respect Local Knowledge: Villagers know their geography best. Community participation in flood control plans is essential.

3. Alternatives to Embankments: Rivers should be given more space to spread silt over the plains, increasing fertility and maintaining groundwater levels.

'Pani Ka Shaap' is not just a book; it is a saga of the tolerance, struggle, and helplessness of Bihar's people. It warns us that the attempt to 'conquer' nature ultimately leads to destruction. True development lies in restoring the river's dignity and the people's livelihood.

Nita Naval Dinesh Kumar Mishra: Book Conclusion

Mithila's Rivers and the Heart-Wrenching Story of Floods: Dr. Dinesh Kumar Mishra's Historical and Ideological Contribution: The Barh Mukti Abhiyan: Mithila's Hydro-Ecology, Engineering, and Cultural Consciousness

The role of rivers and floods in the geographical and cultural landscape of North Bihar has been extremely significant. This region of Mithila, known for its fertile land and rich cultural traditions, has also been continuously afflicted by the 'devastation of floods'. This research report presents a deep analysis of Dr. Dinesh Kumar Mishra's personality, the philosophical and engineering basis of his "Barh Mukti Abhiyan" (BMA), and his unique contribution. Dr. Mishra is not just a civil engineer; he is the 'biographer' of Mithila's rivers and the voice of that society struggling for existence both inside and outside the embankments.

Dr. Dinesh Kumar Mishra: From Engineering to Folk History

Dr. Dinesh Kumar Mishra was born in 1948 in Azamgarh, Uttar Pradesh, but his field of action became the Mithila region of North Bihar. His strong educational background gave him the technical authority to challenge the paradigms of government engineering.

Dr. Mishra's research journey began in 1984 with the breach of the Kosi embankment at Nauhatta in Saharsa district. During the rehabilitation work, he experienced that the embankments built for flood control were actually making the intensity and duration of floods more severe. This experience caused a "paradigm shift" in his thinking, leading him to advocate for "local knowledge" instead of traditional "embankment-based" solutions.

Barh Mukti Abhiyan (BMA): The Ideology of a People's Movement

The Barh Mukti Abhiyan (BMA) is not a formal NGO, but an informal network of village groups, activists, and "flood historians". Under Dr. Mishra's leadership, this movement believes that control over rivers should be returned to society, which knows the traditional ways of fighting and living with floods.

Core Principles and Philosophy of BMA

The main argument of the Barh Mukti Abhiyan is that floods in North Bihar are not just a natural disaster, but the result of "Engineering Witchcraft". Before 1954, the nature of floods in North Bihar was very different. Rivers used to bring fertile silt and spread over the entire area, increasing field fertility. However, after embankment construction, rivers were "imprisoned," causing silt to deposit in the riverbed and raising it.

Some important second-order insights of this movement are:

- Impact of Flood vs. Flood-Control: According to Dr. Mishra, people are less affected by the flood and more by the "flood-control measures". In 1952, the flood-prone area in Bihar was 2.5 million hectares, which increased to 6.88 million hectares by 1999, while 3,465 kilometers of embankments were built during this period. This shows that embankments did not stop floods but instead spread them to new areas.

• Economy of Corruption: Embankment construction and their "maintenance" have become a system where crores of rupees are spent, but only contractors, leaders, and bureaucrats benefit. Between 1990-91 and 1998-99, only 11 km of new embankments were built, but Rs. 270 crore was spent on their maintenance.

• Social Division: Embankments have divided society into "inside" and "outside". Those inside want the embankment to break to lower the water level,

while those outside try to protect it for their safety. This conflict often turns violent.

The Kosi river, called "Bihar's Sorrow", has been central to Dr. Mishra's study. The Kosi's nature is to change its course. In the last 250 years, it has shifted 115 km westward. The 2008 Kushaha tragedy proved that embankments are not a safe measure. At that time, the river carried only 166,000 cusecs of water, while the embankment was designed for 950,000 cusecs. This failure shows how silt accumulation and maintenance negligence create a "time bomb".

Dr. Dinesh Kumar Mishra's uniqueness is that he writes not as an outside expert, but as an integral part of Maithili society, highlighting Mithila's water culture and social issues.

"Dui Patan Ke Bich Mein": Biography of the Kosi

His book "Dui Patan Ke Bich Mein" (2006) is the historical biography of the Kosi river. In this book, he describes everything from the Kosi's geographical location to mythological tales. He writes that in the 12th century, King Lakshmana II built a dam, which people called "Bir Bandh". He also mentions Firoz Shah Tughlaq's 1350 Bengal campaign, where the army had to use elephants to cross the Kosi.

The Plagiarism Controversy and Opposition to Unethical Practices

The Videha movement in literature advocates for "Authenticity" and the "Parallel Stream", which is separate from the alleged casteist agenda of government institutions (like the Sahitya Akademi).

The Videha movement is also known for defending Dr. Mishra's research. It has been alleged that a member of the Sahitya Akademi, Pankaj Jha "Parashar", plagiarized paragraphs from Dr. Mishra's book "Dui Patan Ke Bich Mein" and published them in his Maithili novel "Jalprantar" (2017). The Videha movement strongly opposed this literary theft and championed the importance of Dr. Mishra's original work. Dr. Mishra has allowed all his books to be made freely available in the "Videha Archive" to democratize knowledge.

'Jalprantar' Controversy: Literary Theft and the Crisis of Intellectual Ethics

The impact of Dinesh Kumar Mishra's research has been profound. The controversy surrounding the novel 'Jalprantar' (2017) and its author Pankaj Jha 'Parashar' in the history of Maithili literature is a glaring example. Maithili magazines like 'Videha' leveled serious allegations that Pankaj Jha 'Parashar' incorporated years of Dinesh Kumar Mishra's research, especially from his book 'Dui Patan Ke Bich Mein' (2006) and articles on the Mahananda, into his novel without any credit.

Specific Examples and Evidence of Literary Theft

According to evidence presented by critics, many pages of 'Jalprantar' appear to be verbatim translations or copies of Dinesh Kumar Mishra's original research. For example, the data on deaths from malaria, kala-azar, and cholera in the Kosi region between 1923 and 1946 (783,000), presented in a specific sequence in Mishra's book, appears on page 103 of 'Jalprantar'. Similarly, the description of the 12th-century 'Bir Bandh' and the historical account of Firoz Shah Tughlaq's army crossing the Kosi with elephants and ropes seem directly lifted from Mishra's writings.

Attack on Institutional Corruption and the 'Parallel Stream'

This controversy was not limited to literary theft; it also exposed casteist and ideological polarization within Maithili's institutional structures (Sahitya Akademi, Delhi, and Maithili Akademi, Patna). Critics argued that authors like Pankaj Jha 'Parashar' receive institutional patronage, while researchers like Dinesh Kumar Mishra, who are actually exposing ground realities, are marginalized.

Preamble:

Dinesh Kumar Mishra's 'Dui Patan Ke Bich Mein' is the historical autobiography of the Kosi river; he has also written the historical autobiographies of other Mithila rivers, such as Bandini Mahananda, Bagmati Ki Sadgati!, Dui Patan Ke Bich Mein... (Kosi Nadi Ki Kahani), Na Ghaat Na Ghar, Bagavat Par Majboor Mithila Ki Kamla Nadi, Bhutahi Nadi Aur Takniki Jhad-Phook, The Kamla River and People On Collision Course, Bhutahi Balan-Story of a ghost river and engineering witchcraft, Refugees of the Kosi Embankments. The works of Pankaj Jha Parashar, a member of the Sahitya

Akademi's Maithili Advisory Committee, have been translated paragraph by paragraph into Maithili from these books and published as novels under his name. This is called research by plagiarist author Kamalanand Jha, a pseudo-critic! It should be clarified that both the plagiarist author and the pseudo-critic are in the Hindi department of Aligarh Muslim University. This research belongs to Dinesh Kumar Mishra, who holds a B.Tech. (1968) and M.Tech. (1970) in Civil and Structural Engineering from IIT Kharagpur, and is qualified for such research. When enrollment isn't possible in a subject, people, defeated and exhausted, enroll in Hindi; otherwise, Kamalanand Jha would have understood that this research could only be by a civil engineer. Hindi and Maithili screenshots are attached.

Dinesh Kumar Mishra is not from Mithila, but he has written the stories of all of Mithila's rivers. We are grateful to him, and the people of Mithila can never repay their debt to him. But the ingratitude received from those greedy for mainstream awards and positions has proven itself again. About ten or twelve years ago, this author was also rescued by Taranand Viyogi, who wrote that he was so influenced by others' poetry that he unconsciously incorporated their material into his own work. Now this Kamalanand Jha has taken his shelter, but unfortunately! In order to promote Brahmanism, Kamalanand Jha holds onto the leftist facade and wants to sacrifice social justice. The parallel stream is aware of this. People trying to escape from the ceiling become communists, and now Brahmins seeking protection take refuge in leftism; such people have greatly harmed communism.

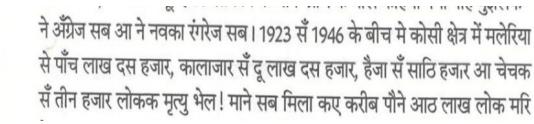
All of Dinesh Kumar Mishra's books are now available with his permission in the Videha Archive: http://videha.co.in/pothi.htm

One point to note: when Bill Gates was asked if he was delaying the Xbox in India due to fear of piracy, his answer was that Microsoft never delays a product due to piracy. In the Videha Archive, we will continue to enrich it without such risk, because in the parallel stream, not all fish in the pond rot due to a few rotten ones; we keep removing the rotten fish one by one.

Final Attack on Syndicated Criticism.

मूल दिनेश कुमार मिश्र **(**दुइ पाटन के बीच में... २००६**):** यह ध्यान देने की बात है कि 1923 से 1946 के बीच कोसी क्षेत्र में मलेरिया से 5,10,000, कालाजार से 2,10,000, हैजे से 60,000 तथा चेचक से 3,000 मौतें (कुल 7,83,000) हुईं।

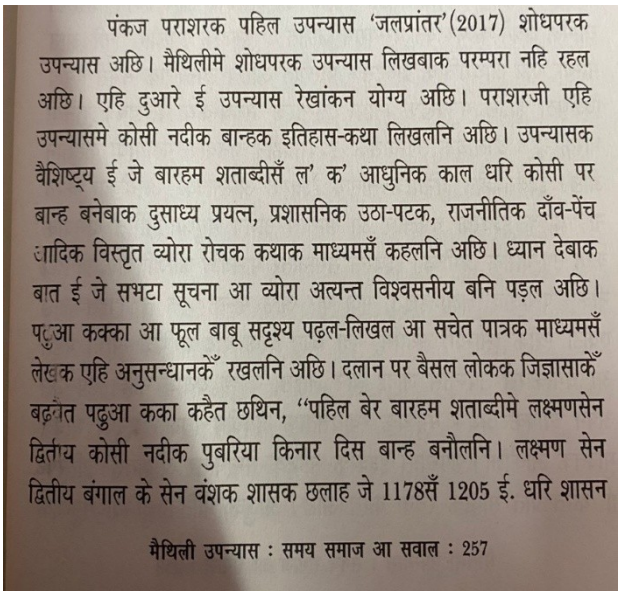
चोर पंकज झा पराशर **(**साहित्य अकादेमीक मैथिली परामर्शदात्री समितिक सदस्य**) [**जलप्रांतर २०१७ **(**पृ. १०३**)]:**


ने अँग्रेज सब आ ने नवका रंगरेज सब। 1923 सँ 1946 के बीच मे कोसी क्षेत्र में मलेरिया
से पाँच लाख दस हजार, कालाजार सँ दू लाख दस हजार, हैजा सँ साठि हजार आ चेचक
सँ तीन हजार लोकक मृत्यु भेल! माने सब मिला कए करीब पौने आठ लाख लोक मरि

मूल दिनेश कुमार मिश्र **(**दुइ पाटन के बीच में... २००६**):** भारतवर्ष में बिहार में कोसी नदी को बांधने का काम 12वीं शताब्दी में किसी राजा लक्ष्मण द्वितीय ने करवाया था और इस काम के लिए उसने प्रजा से 'बीर' की उपाधि पाई और नदी का तटबन्ध 'बीर बांध' कहलाया। इस तटबन्ध के अवशेष अभी भी सुपौल जिले में भीम नगर से कोई 5 किलोमीटर दक्षिण में दिखाई पड़ते हैं। डॉ. फ्रांसिस बुकानन (1810-11) का अनुमान था कि यह बांध किसी किले की सुरक्षा के लिए बनी बाहरी दीवार रहा होगा क्योंकि यह बांध धौस नदी के पश्चिमी किनारे पर तिलयुगा से उसके संगम तक 32 किलोमीटर की दूरी में फैला हुआ था। डॉ. डब्लू.डब्लू. हन्टर (1877) बुकानन के इस तर्क के साथ सहमत नहीं थे कि यह बांध किसी किले की सुरक्षा दीवार था। स्थानीय लोगों के हवाले से हन्टर का मानना था कि अधिकांश लोग इसे किले की दीवार नहीं मानते और उनके हिसाब से यह कुछ और ही चीज थी मगर वह निश्चित रूप से कुछ कहने की स्थिति में नहीं थे। फिर भी जो आम धारणा बनती है वह यह है कि यह कोसी नदी के किनारे बना कोई तटबन्ध रहा होगा जिससे नदी की धारा को पश्चिम की ओर खिसकने से रोका जा सके। लोगों का यह भी कहना था कि ऐसा

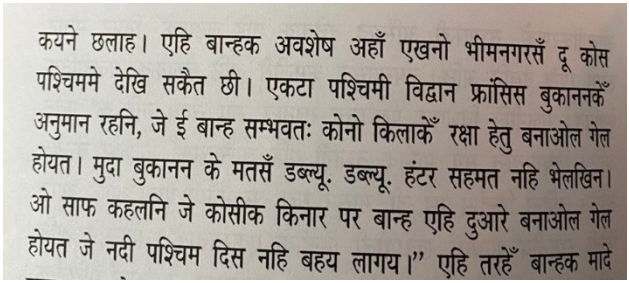
लगता था कि इस तटबन्ध का निर्माण कार्य एकाएक रोक दिया गया होगा।

छद्म समीक्षक कमलानन्द झा द्वारा चोर उपन्यासकारक पीठ ठोकब, देखू छद्म समीक्षक कमलानन्द झा द्वारा उद्धृत चोर पंकज झा पराशर **(**मैथिली उपन्यास, समय, समाज आ सवाल पृ. २५७-२५८**):**



पंकज पराशरक पहिल उपन्यास 'जलप्रांतर'(2017) शोधपरक उपन्यास अछि। मैथिलीमे शोधपरक उपन्यास लिखबाक परम्परा नहि रहल अछि। एहि दुआरे ई उपन्यास रेखांकन योग्य अछि। पराशरजी एहि उपन्यासमे कोसी नदीक बान्हक इतिहास-कथा लिखलनि अछि। उपन्यासक वैशिष्ट्य ई जे बारहम शताब्दीसँ ल' क' आधुनिक काल धरि कोसी पर बान्ह बनेबाक दुसाध्य प्रयत्न, प्रशासनिक उठा-पटक, राजनीतिक दाँव-पेंच आदिक विस्तृत व्योरा रोचक कथाक माध्यमसँ कहलनि अछि। ध्यान देबाक बात ई जे सभटा सूचना आ व्योरा अत्यन्त विश्वसनीय बनि पड़ल अछि। पढुआ कक्का आ फूल बाबू सदृश्य पढ़ल-लिखल आ सचेत पात्रक माध्यमसँ लेखक एहि अनुसन्धानकेँ रखलनि अछि। दलान पर बैसल लोकक जिज्ञासाकेँ बढ़ैत पढुआ कका कहैत छथिन, "पहिल बेर बारहम शताब्दीमे लक्ष्मणसेन द्वितीय कोसी नदीक पुबरिया किनार दिस बान्ह बनौलनि। लक्ष्मण सेन द्वितीय बंगाल के सेन वंशक शासक छलाह जे 1178सँ 1205 ई. धरि शासन

मैथिली उपन्यास : समय समाज आ सवाल : 257



कयने छलाह। एहि बान्हक अवशेष अहाँ एखनो भीमनगरसँ दू कोस पश्चिममे देखि सकैत छी। एकटा पश्चिमी विद्वान फ्रांसिस बुकाननकेँ अनुमान रहनि, जे ई बान्ह सम्भवतः कोनो किलाकेँ रक्षा हेतु बनाओल गेल होयत। मुदा बुकानन के मतसँ डब्ल्यू. डब्ल्यू. हंटर सहमत नहि भेलखिन। ओ साफ कहलनि जे कोसीक किनार पर बान्ह एहि दुआरे बनाओल गेल होयत जे नदी पश्चिम दिस नहि बहय लागय।" एहि तरहेँ बान्हक मादे

चोर पंकज झा पराशर **(**साहित्य अकादेमीक मैथिली परामर्शदात्री समितिक सदस्य**) [**जलप्रांतर २०१७ **(**पृ. ३१**)]:**

पढ़ुआ कका पछिला गप कैँ आगाँ बढ़बैत कहलखिन, 'फूल बाबू, कोसी नदीक बेसिन प्राचीन काल सँ मनुक्खक निवास लेल उपयुक्त स्थान रहल अछि। बारहम-तेरहम सदी मे भारत मे जखन कइक टा नदी सुखा गेल, तँ ओहि ठामक पशुचारक समाजक लोक एतय आबि कए बसलाह। तहिये सँ बढ़ैत जनसंख्या आ कोसी नदीक बदलैत प्रवाहक मध्य टकराहटि होमय लागल। नदीक अनियंत्रित धारा कैँ लोक बाढ़ि बूझय लागल। पहिल बेर बारहम शताब्दी मे लक्ष्मणसेन द्वितीय कोसी नदीक पुबरिया किनार दिस बान्ह बनौलनि। लक्ष्मणसेन द्वितीय बंगाल के सेन वंशक शासक छलाह, जे 1178 सँ 1205 ईस्वी धरि शासन कयनैँ छलाह। एहि बान्हक अवशेष अहाँ एखनो भीमनगर सँ दू कोस पश्चिम मे देखि सकैत छी। एकटा पश्चिमी विद्वान फ्रांसिस बुकानन के अनुमान रहनि, जे ई बान्ह संभवत: कोनो किला के रक्षा हेतु बनाओल गेल होयत। मुदा बुकानन के मत सँ डब्लू. डब्लू. हंटर सहमत नहि भेलखिन। ओ साफ कहलखिन, जे कोसीक किनार पर बान्ह एहि दुआरे बनाओल गेल होयत, जे नदी पच्छिम दिस नहि बह' लागय।' पढ़ुआ कका सँ मुँहजबानी एतेक रास ऐतिहासिक तथ्य सुनियो कए फूल बाबू सहमति मे मूड़ी नहि डोलेलखिन। जाहि सँ ओतय बैसल लोक सबहक उत्सुकता और बढ़ि गेलनि, जे गप मे एहेन कोन तथ्य रहि गेलै जे फूल बाबू संतुष्ट नहि भेलखिन? लोक कैँ बुझेलनि जे फूल बाबू शास्त्रार्थ के अखड़हा पर माटि फेकि रहल छथिन। पढ़ुआ कका कैँ आइ जोड़ीदार भेटि गेलनि!

जलप्रांतर / 31

मूल दिनेश कुमार मिश्र **(**दुइ पाटन के बीच में... २००६**):** कोसी के प्रवाह कि भयावहता की एक झलकफिरोजशाह तुगलक की फौज के सन् 1354 में बंगाल से दिल्ली लौटने के समय मिलती है। बताया जाता है कि जब सुल्तान की फौजें कोसी के किनारे पहुँचीं तो देखा कि नदी के दूसरे किनारे पर हाजी शम्सुद्दीन इलियास की फौजें मुकाबले के लिए तैयार खड़ी हैं। यह वही हाजी शम्सुद्दीन थे जिन्होंने हाजीपुर तथा समस्तीपुर शहर बसाये थे। फिरोज की फौजें शायद कुरसेला के आस-पास किसी जगह पर कोसी के किनारे सोच में पड़ गईं। नदी की रफ्तार उन्हें आगे बढ़ने से रोक रही थी। आखिरकार फैसला हुआ कि नदी के साथ-साथ उत्तर की ओर बढ़ा जाय और जहाँ नदी पार करने लायक हो जाय वहाँ पानी की थाह ली जाये। सुल्तान की फौजें

प्रायः सौ कोस ऊपर गईं और जियारन के पास, जो कि उसी स्थान पर अवस्थित था जहाँ नदी पहाड़ों से मैदानों में उतरती थी, नदी को पार किया। नदी की धारा तो यहाँ पतली जरूर थी पर प्रवाह इतना तेज था कि पाँच-पाँच सौ मन के भारी पत्थर नदी में तिनकों की तरह बह रहे थे। जहाँ नदी को पार करना मुमकिन लगा उसके दोनों ओर सुल्तान ने हाथियों की कतार खड़ी कर दी और नीचे वाली कतार में रस्से लटकाये गये जिससे कि यदि कोई आदमी बहता हुआ हो तो इस रस्सों की मदद से उसे बचाया जा सके। शम्सुद्दीन ने कभी सोचा भी न था कि सुल्तान की फौजें कोसी को पार कर लेंगी और जब उस को इस बात का पता लगा कि सुलतान की फौजों ने कोसी को पार करने में कामयाबी पा ली है तो वह भाग निकला।

चोर पंकज झा पराशर **(**साहित्य अकादेमीक मैथिली परामर्शदात्री समितिक सदस्य**) [**जलप्रांतर २०१७ **(**पृ. १०५**)]:**

'बेश, तँ सुनू। 1354 मे फिरोजशाह तुगलक के फौज जखन बंगाल सँ दिल्ली घुरि रहल छल, तँ कोसीक प्रवाह बहुत तेज छलै। तुगलकी सेना जखन कोसी के किनार पर पहुँचल, तँ कोसीक ओहि पार मे हाजी शम्सउद्दीन इलियास के सेना तुगलकी सेना सँ मोकाबला करबाक लेल अस्त्र–शस्त्र ल' कए तैयार छल। ई वएह हाजी शम्सउद्दीन छलाह, जे हाजीपुर आ समस्तीपुर नगर बसौनैं रहथि। फिरोजशाह तुगलक के सेना संभवतः कूरसेला के आस–पास कोसी के तेज धार देखि कए सोच मे पड़ि गेल। पानिक रफ्तार देखि कए तुगलकी सेना कैं नदी पार करबाक हिम्मत नहि भ' रहल छलै। अंततः तुगलकी सेनापति तय कयलनि, जे नदीक किनारे–किनार उत्तर दिस बढ़ल जाय। जतय जा कए नदीक पाट कनैं कम चौड़ि पड़य, ओतय पानिक थाह लेल जायत। एहि आशा मे फौज उत्तर दिस बढ़ैत रहल। कुरसेला सँ सय कोस आगाँ गेलाक बाद कोसी के पेट कनैं शिकस्त चुझैलै। कोसी ओतहि पहाड़ सँ नीचाँ उतरैत अछि। पानिक वेग के अनुमान एहि सँ कयल जा सकैए, जे पाँच–पाँच सय मनक पाथर कोसी मे खढ़ जकाँ बहि रहल छल। तुगलकी सेनापति कैं जतय नदी पार करब कनैं आसान चुझैलनि, ओतय एक लाइन मे सैकड़ों टा हाथी कैं ठाढ़ क' देल गेल। नीचाँ वला लाइन मे बड़का–बड़का रस्सा लटका देल गेल, जे जँ क्यो पानि मे भासि जायत, रस्सा के मदति सँ निकालि लेल जायत। एहि तरहैं फिरोजशाह तुगलकक सेना कोसी पार क' गेल। हाजी शम्सउद्दीन सपनो मे नहि सोचनैं छल,जे तुगलकी सेना कोसी पार क' जायत। जखन हाजी शम्सउद्दीन कैं पता लगलै जे तुगलकी सेना कोसी पार क' चुकल अछि, तँ ओ डरे सँ पड़ा गेल। तँ एहि कोसीक तेज धार के ल' कए एतेक आत्मविश्वास मे छल हाजी शम्सउद्दीन।'

Original Dinesh Kumar Mishra (Dui Patan Ke Bich Mein... 2006): It is noteworthy that between 1923 and 1946, in the Kosi region, 510,000 died from malaria, 210,000 from kala-azar, 60,000 from cholera, and 3,000 from smallpox (total 783,000).

Plagiarist Pankaj Jha Parashar (Member, Sahitya Akademi Maithili Advisory Committee) [Jalprantar 2017 (p. 103)]:

Original Dinesh Kumar Mishra (Dui Patan Ke Bich Mein... 2006): The work of damming the Kosi river in Bihar in India was done in the 12th century by a king named Lakshmana II, and for this work, he received the title 'Bir' from his subjects, and the river embankment came to be called 'Bir Bandh'. Remains of this embankment are still visible about 5 kilometers south of Bhimnagar in Supaul district. Dr. Francis Buchanan (1810-11) estimated that this dam might have been an outer wall for the security of some fort, as it extended for 32 kilometers from the western bank of the Dhaus river to its confluence with the Tilyuga. Dr. W.W. Hunter (1877) disagreed with Buchanan's argument that this dam was a fort's defensive wall. Citing locals, Hunter believed that most people did not consider it a fort wall and according to them, it was something else, but he was not in a position to say for sure. Still, the common notion is that it must have been some embankment on the bank of the Kosi river to prevent its current from shifting westwards. People also said that it seemed the construction of this embankment was stopped abruptly.

Pseudo-critic Kamalanand Jha applauding the plagiarist novelist, see the citation by pseudo-critic Kamalanand Jha of plagiarist Pankaj Jha Parashar (Maithili novel, Samay, Samaj aur Sawal pp. 257-258):

Plagiarist Pankaj Jha Parashar (Member, Sahitya Akademi Maithili Advisory Committee) [Jalprantar 2017 (p. 31)]:

Original Dinesh Kumar Mishra (Dui Patan Ke Bich Mein... 2006): A glimpse of the horror of the Kosi's flow is seen when Firoz Shah Tughlaq's army returned from Bengal to Delhi in 1354. It is said that when the Sultan's forces reached the banks of the Kosi, they saw the forces of Haji Shamsuddin Ilyas ready for battle on the other side. This was the same Haji Shamsuddin who founded the cities of Hajipur and Samastipur. Firoz's forces perhaps pondered on the banks of the Kosi somewhere near Kursela. The river's speed prevented them from advancing. Finally, it was decided to proceed north along the river and find a place to measure the depth where crossing became feasible. The Sultan's forces went about 100 kos upstream and crossed the river near Jiyaran, which was located where the river descends from the mountains to the plains. The current was narrower here, but the flow was so fast that heavy stones weighing five hundred man were flowing like straw. Where crossing seemed possible, the Sultan lined up elephants on both sides, and ropes were hung from the lower

line so that if anyone was swept away, they could be rescued. Shamsuddin never imagined the Sultan's forces would cross the Kosi, and when he learned they had succeeded, he fled.

Plagiarist Pankaj Jha Parashar (Member, Sahitya Akademi Maithili Advisory Committee) [Jalprantar 2017 (p. 105)]:

Dinesh Kumar Mishra: Development and Ideological Departure of a Multifaceted Personality

Dinesh Kumar Mishra was born in 1946 (according to some sources, 1948) in Azamgarh district, Uttar Pradesh. His educational background was connected to India's top technical institutions. He obtained a B.Tech. in Civil Engineering from the Indian Institute of Technology (IIT), Kharagpur, in 1968, and later an M.Tech. in Structural Engineering from the same institution in 1970. The ideological turning point in his life came in 1984 when, witnessing the devastation caused by the Kosi embankment breach in Saharsa, he was compelled to question whether modern engineering was actually providing solutions or making problems more complex. By the time he received his doctorate from Veer Narmad South Gujarat University in 2006, Mishra had established himself as an active environmentalist and river historian.

Mishra's methodology exhibits a unique duality: on one hand, he possesses the technical perspective of an IIT; on the other, he attempts to understand the cultural existence of rivers through folk tales, myths, songs, and poetry. His selection as an 'Ashoka Fellow' and being honored with the 'Bhagirath Prayas Samman' (2016) are proof that his research has taken the form of a broader social movement.

Bandini Mahananda: River's Liberation and the Trap of Embankments

The very title 'Bandini Mahananda' expresses Mishra's fundamental principle, where he terms embankments as a 'prison' for rivers. The Mahananda, a border river flowing between Bihar and Bengal, has been a victim of technical interventions that have disrupted its natural dynamics for decades. Mishra argues that the policy of confining rivers like the Mahananda within embankments not only increased the devastation of floods but also severed the centuries-old cultural and ecological relationship between the river and its riparian communities, which he calls 'cultural ownership'.

### Economics of Embankments and Technical Analysis of Failure

Mishra understood in great detail how silt accumulation inside embankments causes the riverbed to rise above the surrounding land, turning the embankment into a 'time bomb'. His studies in the Mahananda basin show that despite massive investments in 'flood-control' according to government data, the flood-prone area continuously increased. He calls this 'Engineering Witchcraft', where technical solutions ignore local topography and hydrology.

### Ecological Impact and the Problem of 'Water-logging'

A major problem in the context of the Mahananda is waterlogging. Embankments not only prevent river water from going out but also hinder rainwater from outside areas from merging into the river. As a result, agricultural land remains submerged for months, devastating the rabi crop and local livelihoods. Mishra's research points out that traditionally, people here knew how to 'live with floods', where floodwater increased soil fertility, not destruction.

### Mithila's Water History and the 1948 Legislative Debate

To understand the policy shifts towards rivers, Dinesh Kumar Mishra also deeply analyzed the political debates soon after independence. The debate in the Bihar Legislative Assembly on September 18, 1948, is extremely important in this regard. In that debate, leaders like Deep Narayan Singh, Prabhunath Singh, and Murli Manohar Prasad expressed their views on floods and embankments.

Murli Manohar Prasad lamented the destruction of the prevalent irrigation system of that time and understood how the Indigo Planters had prevented the maintenance of old canals and sluice gates, causing the entire system to collapse. This debate clarifies that the demand for embankments was often made for immediate relief, while the scientific understanding of long-term impacts was disputed even then.

### Bagmati and Kosi: The Tragedy of Communities Imprisoned within Embankments

A large part of Dinesh Kumar Mishra's research focuses on the human crisis of communities trapped between the embankments of the Bagmati and Kosi rivers. In the context of the Bagmati project, he studied villages like 'Masaha Alam' in Sitamarhi district, where out of 420 families, only 104 could be rehabilitated after forty years. These families are still forced to live in hellish conditions on the embankment or by the railway line.

Mishra notes that corruption in these projects was such that officials demanded 'nazarana' or a 10% commission even for the small plots allocated to the displaced. When the villagers of Masaha Alam refused to pay this bribe, they were deprived of rehabilitation for decades.

## Barh Mukti Abhiyan: Empowering Communities

Dinesh Kumar Mishra is not just a writer; he also leads an active people's movement through the 'Barh Mukti Abhiyan'. This movement organizes communities in flood-prone areas of North Bihar to revive decentralized and traditional methods of flood management.

Mishra believes the most effective way to deal with floods is to rejuvenate the drainage systems of chaurs (local water bodies). He has provided technical assistance to many groups so they can carry out drainage work themselves and restart agriculture on land that became useless due to waterlogging.

## Portrayal of Rivers in Maithili Literature and Ideological Struggle

The portrayal of rivers in Maithili literature has been not just as natural scenery, but also as a symbol of human struggle. The works of Dinesh Kumar Mishra provided many authors with a factual basis.

However, a 'Parallel Stream' has emerged in Maithili intellectual circles, opening a front against government academies and established critics. In this struggle, the 'biographies' of rivers by Dinesh Kumar Mishra are being used like an ideological weapon.

## Terminology and Discourse: From 'Engineering Witchcraft' to 'Cultural Ownership'

The terminology used in Dinesh Kumar Mishra's research reflects the depth of his ideological discourse. Through 'Engineering Witchcraft', he attacks the modern superstition that believes concrete structures can completely control nature. In contrast, his concept of 'Cultural Ownership' suggests that the right to manage rivers should belong to the local communities who have lived with them for centuries.

Mishra argues that modern flood control policy creates 'reciprocal inaccessibility' – during floods, reaching affected areas becomes impossible, and during calm periods, waterlogging keeps those areas cut off from the mainstream of development.

Future Challenges and Relevance of Research

Today, with climate change altering rainfall patterns, the relevance of Dinesh Kumar Mishra's research has only increased. His predictions about the Kosi and Mahananda, made decades ago, are proving true. He is currently working on the Gandak and Ghaghra rivers to create a complete 'ecological map' of North Bihar's rivers.

Mishra's work is not just for policymakers but also serves as a guide for sociologists and literary figures. He reminds us that rivers are not just cubic seconds of water, but carriers of "forests, mountains, and the blessings of sages," and preserving their sanctity and freedom is our collective responsibility.

Dr. Mishra's work is not limited to the Kosi; he has written the "biography" of almost all major rivers of Mithila.

• Mahananda: His book "Bandini Mahananda" (1994) highlights the problems of the border river between Bihar and Bengal.

• Bagmati: In "Bagmati Ki Sadgati!" (2012), he showed how a river that was a boon became a "curse" due to embankments.

• Kamla: His research on the Kamla river and the struggles of its people in "Kamla River and People on Collision Course" is highly significant.

• Bhutahi Balan: In "Bhutahi Nadi Aur Takniki Jhad-Phook", he showed how engineering arrogance failed to control an unstable river.

• Gandak: He is currently working on the history of the Gandak and Ghaghra rivers, which would complete the river-scape of North Bihar.

Dr. Mishra and BMA's fundamental insistence is on the art of "living with floods". The people of Mithila earlier managed water through "chaurs", "dhaap", and "dhaar". The silt-laden water used to go to fields, leading to bumper yields of foxnut, fish, and paddy.

However, current government policy focuses on large projects like "river linking" and "national waterways" (National Waterways Act, 2016). There are plans to make the Gandak (NW-37) and Kosi (NW-58) national waterways to connect Nepal to the sea. Dr. Mishra warns that these projects ignore the serious problem of silt and could cause further ecological damage.

Dr. Dinesh Kumar Mishra's journey extends from IIT's "rigid engineering" to Mithila's "soft folk culture". His work proves that a river is not just a water stream, but the artery of society. The Barh Mukti Abhiyan is not just opposition to government policy, but a call for society to turn back to its roots.

If we want to save North Bihar from destruction, we must learn from Dr. Mishra's "flood history" and give engineering a human face, making it nature-friendly.

The place of rivers in the geographical, social, and cultural consciousness of Mithila is not limited to being a source of water; it is the very foundation of its civilization. When we talk about Mithila's rivers, a picture of floods, displacement, and struggle emerges, which cannot be understood with just an engineering degree. Making this serious subject the goal of his life, Dr. Dinesh Kumar Mishra established a discourse that challenges the failure of modern water management policy based on folk memory and historical evidence.

Introducing Dr. Dinesh Kumar Mishra merely as a river expert would be an injustice to his extensive research and struggle. He is a 'river-historian' who used his technical education not to 'control' rivers, but to convey the river's 'pain' to the public. His writings, known as timeless works like Bandini

Mahananda, Dui Patan Ke Bich Mein, Bagmati Ki Sadgati, and Bagavat Par Majboor Mithila Ki Kamla Nadi, are essential documents for understanding Mithila's water culture and the politics of floods.

Personal and Educational Background: Transformation of an Engineer

Dinesh Kumar Mishra was born in 1948. His educational journey is highly impressive, strengthening the scientific basis of his research. In 1968, he obtained a B.Tech. (Hons.) in Civil Engineering from IIT Kharagpur. Subsequently, in 1970, he earned an M.Tech. in Structural Engineering from the same institute. This engineering background helped him understand the prevalent 'technical supremacy' of the time, which believed that a river could be controlled by damming it with cement and stone walls.

From 1970 to 1984, Dr. Mishra worked as an independent structural consultant. During this period, he designed and supervised the construction of large structures like university buildings, townships, cinema halls, and hospitals. However, the scene he witnessed in 1984 when the Kosi embankment broke at Nauhatta in Saharsa district changed the direction of his life. On September 5, 1984, the Kosi embankment near Hempur village breached, displacing about 500,000 people. After witnessing this tragedy, Mishra left his professional career and dedicated himself to the serious study of river behavior and the problems of flood victims.

Barh Mukti Abhiyan: Conflict between Folk Science and Government Policy

In 1992, Dr. Dinesh Kumar Mishra founded the 'Barh Mukti Abhiyan' (BMA). This is not a traditional NGO, but a people's movement and ideological platform opposing the 'embankment politics' being pursued in the name of flood control. Mishra's main argument is that flood is not just a natural disaster, but the result of government mismanagement and flawed engineering.

According to Mishra, the objective of the Barh Mukti Abhiyan is to inspire people to revive their 'flood memory'. He went from village to village training 'flood historians' who document how floods used to come to villages before the embankments and how people welcomed them. The ideological framework of BMA is based on the following points:

• Living with Floods: Mishra believes stopping floods is impossible; the only option is to create harmony with them.

• Failure of Embankments: Embankments trap river silt, causing the riverbed to rise and making floods more severe.

• Decentralized Solutions: Instead of large dams and embankments, rejuvenate small drainage systems and traditional ahar-pyne systems.

## The Story of the Kosi: 'Dui Patan Ke Bich Mein' and the Tragedy of Displacement

Dr. Mishra's most discussed and serious research is 'Dui Patan Ke Bich Mein - Kosi Nadi Ki Kahani' (2006). In this book, he presents a comprehensive canvas, from the mythological context of the Kosi river to the modern history of embankments. The Kosi, called 'Bihar's Sorrow', is in Mishra's view the 'engineer's sorrow' and the 'politician's boon'.

In this book, he discusses the 'Bir Bandh' built by King Lakshmana II in the 12th century, whose remains can still be seen in Bhimnagar, Supaul district. Mishra proves that embankments were built in ancient times as well, but they were not for blocking the river's flow, but for defensive purposes. When the Kosi project started in the 1950s, it was claimed that embankments would end floods. But Mishra shows with data that the flood-affected area in Bihar, which was 2.5 million hectares in 1954, increased to 6.88 million hectares by 2008.

Another significant book of his, 'Trapped! Between the Devil and Deep Waters' (2008), was published just before the Kosi's Kushaha tragedy, almost like a prophecy. In this book, he clearly stated that when the river's surface rises inside the embankments, it could change its course at any time. Exactly that happened in 2008, when the Kosi breached the embankment to take its old course, flowing east.

## Historical Death and Disease Data in the Kosi Region

In his research, Mishra presents horrifying data from 1923 to 1946, showing how waterlogging caused by railway and road construction during the British era took people's lives.

| Disease | Number of Deaths (1923-1946) |

| : | : |

| Malaria | 510,000 |

| Kala-azar | 210,000 |

| Cholera | 60,000 |

| Smallpox | 3,000 |

| Total Deaths | 783,000 |

Mishra argues that when floods bring water that flows, diseases do not spread. But when water stagnates due to embankments, mosquitoes breed and epidemics spread.

The Plight of Bagmati: 'Bagmati Ki Sadgati!' and Technical Intervention

The Bagmati river is considered highly sacred in Mithila, but in his book 'Bagmati Ki Sadgati!', Dr. Mishra exposed government efforts to destroy this sanctity. The attempt to confine Bagmati, known for changing its course, within embankments proved to be a major failure.

In this, he mentions the polluted water from the 'Riga Sugar Mill' contaminating Bagmati. He uses the term 'Engineering Witchcraft', meaning attempting to control the river merely with concrete without understanding its behavior. Earlier, Bagmati's flood used to fill chaurs, benefiting the 'Garma' crop and increasing fish production. After the embankment, water could not reach the fields, and villages became victims of waterlogging.

Kamla River and People's Revolt: 'Bagavat Par Majboor Mithila Ki Kamla Nadi'

The Kamla river is given the status of 'Mother' in Mithila. Dr. Mishra's book 'The Kamla River and People On Collision Course' describes the geography and irrigation history of the Kamla. From the start of irrigation schemes on the Kamla in the 1950s to the construction of the weir in 1964, Mishra highlights each technical failure.

In the context of the Kamla river, Mishra's main finding is that the people here used the water of 'Kamla' through their traditional ahar-pyne systems. When the government built embankments, water stopped reaching people's fields. Consequently, people often cut the embankment themselves ('public cut') to save their fields. According to Mishra, this 'revolt' is not against the river, but against flawed engineering.

Mahananda's Compulsion: 'Bandini Mahananda' and Politics

Published in 1994, 'Bandini Mahananda' was one of Mishra's early research works. In it, he raised the issue of the Mahananda river flowing on the border of Bihar and West Bengal. The Mahananda's embankment also caused border disputes. In his research, Mishra references the 1937 Patna Flood Conference, where Chief Engineer Captain Hall clearly stated that building embankments in North Bihar was an 'engineering sin'. But politicians ignored this warning to promote their vote banks and contractor practices.

Mishra's analysis shows that the Mahananda's embankment completely destroyed the agricultural cycle of that region. The water that previously brought fertility now causes crops to rot due to months-long waterlogging.

Technical Discourse: Embankments and the Silt Problem

Being a civil engineer, Dr. Mishra explains the failure of embankments on a scientific basis. Rivers originating from the Himalayas carry huge amounts of silt.

• Rising Riverbed: When a river is confined within embankments, silt cannot escape and accumulates in the riverbed, raising its surface by an average of 10 cm per year.

• Embankment Height: As the river rises, the government keeps increasing the embankment height, but there is a limit. When the embankment breaks, the water velocity becomes far more devastating.

• Benefit-Cost Ratio (BC Ratio): According to Mishra, engineers only consider the benefits of construction. They do not calculate the 'social cost' of displacement, disease, and land degradation.

Literary Contribution and the 'Videha' Movement

Dinesh Kumar Mishra is not originally from Mithila (he was born in Uttar Pradesh), but his work on Mithila's rivers is so profound that Maithili literature and journalism have honored him as a 'son of Mithila'. The importance of his work is such that he also became a victim of literary theft. Gajendra Thakur, editor of the Maithili magazine 'Videha', highlighted the case where Pankaj Jha 'Parashar', a member of the Sahitya Akademi's Maithili Advisory Committee, plagiarized several paragraphs from Mishra's book 'Dui Patan Ke Bich Mein' and published them under his name in his novel 'Jalprantar'. This controversy proved that Mishra's research has a 'literary value' that an ordinary writer cannot assimilate without deep study.

All of Mishra's books are now freely available in the 'Videha Archive', with his permission for Maithili-speaking readers.

Awards, Honors, and International Presence

Dr. Dinesh Kumar Mishra's work has been honored with several prestigious national and international awards. He was a member of the United Nations Environment Programme's (UNEP) 'Dams and Development Forum' (2003-07), where he represented people affected by dams. Additionally, he was a member of the 'Flood Control' working group for India's 11th and 12th Five-Year Plans, advocating for policy-level changes.

Conclusion: River's Liberation and the Path Ahead

Dinesh Kumar Mishra's entire life is dedicated to Mithila's rivers and the struggles of its people. His ideas move from 'flood control' to 'flood management' and 'harmony with rivers'. Today, as climate change increases flood devastation, Mishra's philosophy of 'Living with Floods' has become even more relevant.

His writing warns us that if we obstruct the natural flow of rivers, nature will settle the score. Mithila's Mahananda, Kosi, Bagmati, and Kamla are not just water-carrying streams; they are the life, culture, and identity of the people. The ideological foundation Dr. Mishra has provided to save this identity will guide many generations to come.

The society of Mithila will forever be indebted to Dr. Dinesh Kumar Mishra for this herculean effort. His work teaches us that when an engineer thinks with his heart, he does not remain confined to dams but also preserves people's 'memory'.

Nita Naval Dinesh Kumar Mishra

Dinesh Kumar Mishra, B.Tech. in Civil Engineering (1968) and M.Tech. in Structural Engineering (1970) from IIT Kharagpur. Expert on floods in Mithila. Has published books on almost all major rivers of Mithila, such as Uttar Bihar Ki Vyatha Katha (1990), Kosi- Umar Kaid Se Saza-E-Maut Tak (1992), Bandini Mahananda (1994), Boya Ped Babool Ka- Baadh Niyantran Ka Rahasya (2000), Bagavat Par Majboor Mithila Ki Kamla Nadi (2004), Bhutahi Nadi Aur Takniki Jhad-Phook (2005), Dui Patan Ke Bich Mein- Kosi Nadi Ki Kahani (2006), and Bagmati Ki Sadgati (2010).

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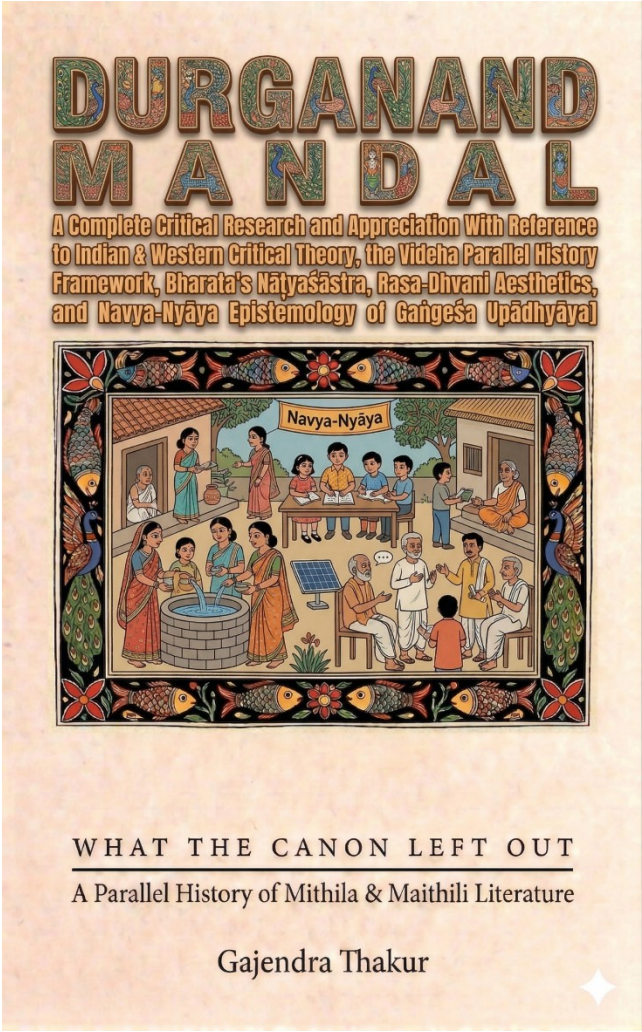
**LESSON 023 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**




# DURGANAND MANDAL

*A Complete Critical Research and Appreciation*

*With Reference to Indian & Western Critical Theory, the Videha Parallel History Framework,*

*Bharata's Nāṭyaśāstra, Rasa-Dhvani Aesthetics,*

*and Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya*

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## Abstract

This monograph presents a complete critical research and appreciation of the literary works of Durganand Mandal (दुर्गानन्द मण्डल), a contemporary Maithili writer working in the tradition of democratic, grassroots, and non-Brahmin literary expression. An assistant teacher (Sahayak Shikshak) at Utkramit Vidyalaya, Jhitki-Banagaon, Madhubani, Bihar, Mandal began writing Maithili literature in 2009 under the inspirational mentorship of the celebrated Maithili writer Jagdish Prasad Mandal. His principal works examined in this study include the collection Sanchiyka (a compilation of stories, criticism, and literary essays), the story collection Katha Kusum (कथा कुसुम), a Chakshu (चक्षु) volume, and individual stories, micro-fictions (laghu-katha), critical reviews, poems, and social essays archived in the Videha eJournal.

This study applies a layered critical framework: (i) Indian classical aesthetics — Bharata's Nāṭyaśāstra (Rasa, Bhāva, Sāttvika, Dhvani), Ānandavardhana's Dhvani theory, Abhinavagupta's rasāsvādana, and Kuntaka's Vakrokti; (ii) Navya-Nyāya epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya — Pramāṇa, Vyāpti, Pakṣatā, Anuvyavasāya — as an instrument of literary epistemology; (iii) the Videha Parallel History Framework of Gajendra Thakur, which situates Mandal in the suppressed democratic tradition of Maithili literature; and (iv) Western critical frameworks including Marxist literary theory, New Historicism, postcolonial theory, and realist narrative theory. The study argues that Mandal's work constitutes a vital subaltern intervention — writing from below, from the village, from the non-Brahmin perspective — and that his contribution to the Bīhani Kathā (seed story) tradition, social criticism, and literary pedagogy makes him an indispensable voice in contemporary Maithili letters.

# I. Bio-Bibliographic Introduction: Durganand Mandal in Context

## 1.1 Life and Identity

Durganand Mandal was born and raised in the village of Godhanapur (Nirmal), situated in the Nirmal block of Supaul district, Bihar — a region within the cultural and ecological heartland of Mithila, at the confluence of the Koshi and Bagmati river systems. He is currently employed as a Sahayak Shikshak (assistant teacher) at Utkramit Vidyalaya, Jhitki-Banagaon, in Madhubani district — a school located in the Harlakhi Block, a predominantly lower-caste and OBC (Other Backward Class) rural area. This biographical location is not incidental: it shapes every dimension of his literary practice.

Mandal belongs to a non-Brahmin, non-Kayastha social community — the groups that the Videha Parallel History Framework identifies as systematically excluded from the Maithili literary establishment dominated by Maithil Brahmin and Karna Kayastha elites. In a pointed statement recorded in the Sanchiyka volume, Mandal articulates this condition directly: the non-Brahmin writer faces a dual barrier — the alien vocabulary of the literary establishment (words never spoken in his community's everyday life) and the structural exclusion from publication, awards, and recognition. He identifies his own trajectory as one of 'unfolding from within a cocoon' (ajhurael jaka jhapael) — hidden, not absent.

His entry into Maithili literature in 2009 was catalysed by the encouragement of Jagdish Prasad Mandal — the foremost living Maithili novelist, recipient of the Sahitya Akademi Award (2021) for Pangu, and the central figure of the democratic parallel tradition. Mandal has also drawn sustenance from Gajendra Thakur's Videha eJournal, which he identifies as having revealed to him the richness of Maithili vocabulary employed outside the Brahmin literary register — words present in his own community's speech but suppressed from the written tradition.

## 1.2 Published and Archived Works

| | |
|---|---|
| **Title** | Sanchiyka (संचियका) — Selected Works |
| **Genre** | Collection: Stories, Criticism, Literary Essays, |

| | |
|---|---|
| | Lagu-katha, Poems, Social Essays |
| **Content** | Interview with Munnaji; story 'Daktar Karmaveer'; Laghu-katha 'Kukarm'; Novel review of Jagdish Prasad Mandal's Jivan-Sangharsh and Jivan-Maran; Drama review of Bechan Thakur; Essay on Independence Day; Stories 'Lal Bhouji,' 'Paras,' 'Baklel,' 'Kisna Mutti'; Poems; Pothisamiksha |
| **Archive** | Videha eJournal, www.videha.co.in |

| | |
|---|---|
| **Title** | Katha Kusum (कथा कुसुम) — Story Blossom |
| **Genre** | Short story collection |
| **Archive** | Videha / Videha Pothi Archive |
| **Significance** | A dedicated anthology of Maithili short stories in the social-realist mode |

| | |
|---|---|
| **Title** | Chakshu (चक्षु) — The Eye |
| **Genre** | Literary collection / critical anthology |
| **Archive** | Videha / Videha Pothi Archive |
| **Significance** | The title suggests a mode of seeing and witnessing — thematic of Mandal's critical practice |

| | |
|---|---|
| **Title** | Individual Works in Videha eJournal |
| **Genre** | Stories, Lagu-katha (micro-fiction), Pothisamiksha (book reviews), Poems, Social essays |
| **Themes** | Village life, Koshi floods, casteism, education, superstition, rural-urban migration, |

| | |
|---|---|
| | pharmaceutical exploitation, gender, festival culture |
| **Archive** | www.videha.co.in (ISSN 2229-547X) |

## 1.3 The Munnaji Interview: A Self-Portrait in Words

One of the most valuable documents in the Sanchiyka is the extended interview conducted by the Videha interviewer 'Munnaji' (Manojkumar Karn, assistant editor of Videha). This interview serves as a literary self-portrait and a manifesto of Mandal's critical position. From it we learn several crucial things. First, he describes his language philosophy: 'The construction of a story is naturally the right words — distance from embellishment is as far as a donkey's head is from horns (gadahak māthame sāng).' This is a rejection of ornate Alaṃkāra-style writing in favour of direct, natural speech — a position aligned with the democratic tradition's valorisation of the laukika (everyday) over the śāstrīya (classical textbook) register.

Second, he articulates a theory of the storytelling voice: when reading aloud, he illuminates every word for the listener's existence (astitva), making the story audible and letting the listener experience pleasure (ānanda). This is a Nāṭyaśāstra-inflected performance theory: the story is not merely read but enacted, with the teller functioning as an Abhivyañjaka (expresser) and the listener as a Sahṛdaya (sensitive receiver).

Third, and most significantly, he addresses the structural exclusion of non-Brahmin writers from Maithili literature with precision and without bitterness. He identifies a historical 'drawn line' (khīṃchal ekaṭā sīmā-rekhā) that makes it extremely difficult for non-Brahmin-Karna-Kayastha writers to cross into public recognition. He names the mechanism: when a non-Brahmin writer picks up a pen, words that were never spoken in his community's life — that he had never heard from anyone's lips — stand before him like enemies. The literary language has been constructed in a way that excludes the everyday vocabulary of non-Brahmin communities. Yet he ends on a note of historical optimism: the situation is changing, and non-Brahmin writers are coming forward.

# II. Textual Analysis: Major Works and Themes

## 2.1 Short Stories: The Social-Realist Village Narrative

### *2.1.1 'Ḍākṭar Karmavīr' — Doctor Karmaveer*

This story, the major narrative of the Sanchiyka collection, is a paradigmatic example of Mandal's social-realist mode. Set on 6 June 2003 — the day when the Prime Minister of India was to lay the foundation stone of a railway bridge over the Koshi at Nirmal — the story establishes its political-historical context with unusual precision. The narrative follows a doctor named Karmaveer who, after years of poverty and struggle in the village, eventually establishes a successful clinic, marries a beautiful wife (Poonam — full moon), and achieves the social recognition denied to him in his youth.

The story operates on two registers simultaneously. On the surface it is a Bildungsroman of upward mobility — the classic 'from rags to riches' narrative. But Mandal's realist detailing of the village chowk — the toddy shop with its earthen pots of fermenting palm wine, the villagers singing 'Tāṛī vālī tāṛī pī ā da...' (Give me toddy, toddy-seller...), the paan shop of Bauwa Kaka, the food stalls, the sensory textures of rural Mithila — grounds this mobility narrative in a specific social ecology. The story's implicit argument is that genuine development (vikāś) must happen within the village, not through migration to the city.

Karmaveer's desire to open a clinic in his own village — 'I want to practice here and serve the village and society' — articulates a counter-narrative to the pervasive 'brain drain' from rural Bihar. The narrator's speech defending village life — 'In the soil and water of the village there is every happiness; no village is inferior to any village; no dhām is inferior to Mithilādhām' — is a lyrical manifesto of rootedness that anticipates the anti-displacement ethos of Mandal's later work.

The description of Karmaveer's wife Poonam — detailed with loving attention to her physical beauty through the conventions of the Sanskrit nāyikāvarnana (description of the heroine) tradition, while grounding her in the social reality of a prosperous professional couple — enacts a characteristic double movement in Mandal's prose: he inhabits classical Maithili descriptive traditions while filling them with contemporary social content.

### *2.1.2 'Lāl Bhouji' — The Red Sister-in-law*

This story, among the most sensuous and socially specific of the collection, is set during the festival of Phāgun (Holi) in a village. It centres on the relationship between Ugan (the younger brother) and his new sister-in-law (bhouji — married just two months earlier to his elder brother Durganand). The story captures the teasing, the playfulness, and the erotic charge of the Holi festival within the structured kinship relations of a Mithila village household.

What makes this story significant beyond its narrative surface is its dense social specification: the description of Lal Bhouji (literally 'Red Sister-in-law,' named for the colour of her clothing and the Holi context) is rendered in the full classical Maithili nāyikāvarnana tradition — detailed physical description from head to toe. Yet the social context is that of a lower-middle-class OBC household, not a royal court. The classical form is appropriated for democratic social content.

The story also documents the Phagua (Holi) folk songs of rural Mithila — including the women's ribald counter-songs ('Ro chhoṛā bajjar khasat...'), the men's songs ('Tohar lahnag uṭhā dev rīmoṭase...'), and the general atmosphere of licensed sexual play that the festival enables. This ethnographic dimension places Mandal in the tradition of Maithili folk-realism — a writer who documents the living oral culture of his community with the precision of an insider and the craft of a literary artist.

### *2.1.3 'Pāras' — The Philosopher's Stone*

This story, which Mandal narrates to his class of ninth-grade girls at the story's beginning, is a tale within a tale — a mise en abyme structure that places the act of storytelling at the story's thematic centre. The inner story concerns a young man named Paras (after the mythological philosopher's stone that turns iron into gold) who sells tea at a stall while studying — ultimately earning an M.A. in Maithili and becoming a teacher.

The story is Mandal's fullest statement of his social philosophy: that no work is shameful (karmā kono kharāp nahin hoet chhai), that honest labour is dignity, and that education and economic self-sufficiency can be achieved simultaneously. Paras's tea-selling is not an obstacle to his education but its means and its symbol: just as the philosopher's stone transforms base metal, Paras transforms his social position through labour and learning.

The story's frame — a male teacher narrating this to an all-girls class, who respond with the collective declaration 'We too want to become Paras, Paras' —

adds a feminist pedagogical dimension. The girls' identification with the male protagonist dissolves the gender boundary: the aspiration to self-transformation through education is universal.

In formal terms, the story demonstrates Mandal's mastery of the nested narrative structure — a form that the Sanskrit Kathā tradition (Kathāsaritsāgara, Pañcatantra) deployed extensively, and that Mandal reinvents for contemporary social-realist purposes.

### *2.1.4 'Baklel' — The Absent-Minded*

This story is a fine example of Mandal's satirical mode — rare in his output but executed with precision when deployed. Saroj Babu is a highly educated but socially inept young man — a 'know-it-all' (Mister Know All) who cannot function without his wife. When she goes to her mother's house (naihar) for the extended Sawan-Bhadra season (the traditional period when new brides visit their parents), he becomes completely dysfunctional: unable to eat, sleep, or attend to basic self-care.

The story's satirical target is male dependency masquerading as affection — the educated man who has achieved intellectual status but remains entirely helpless in the domestic sphere. The climax — Saroj Babu hiding in the kitchen at his in-laws' house during the Durga Puja festival, secretly eating the feast that has been prepared from the two sacrificial goats — and being caught in flagrante delicto by the household, shamed before his sisters-in-law, is rendered with comic precision and genuine humour.

This story demonstrates Mandal's range: from the lyrical social realism of 'Karmaveer' to the satirical domestic comedy of 'Baklel,' he employs different registers with the assurance of a writer who has thoroughly absorbed the spectrum of Maithili narrative traditions.

## 2.2 Micro-Fiction (Lagu-Kathā)

### *2.2.1 'Kukarm' — The Wicked Deed*

This is a complex and structurally intricate piece of micro-fiction — one of the most ambitious items in the Sanchiyka. It weaves together a frame narrative (an astrologer in Dharmapur village, Madhubani, who finds a human skull on a path), an inner narrative (the story of the astrologer's beautiful sixteen-year-old daughter Sunaina and her romantic adventures), and a folktale-within-the-story (the story of the king who demands to know why a fish laughed when it saw the

queen, which is solved by the astrologer's grandson Kukarm, who was born of Sunaina after she accidentally consumed the skull-powder).

The narrative is a tour de force of Maithili folk-narrative technique — the concatenated story structure (within-a-story-within-a-story) that echoes the Kathāsaritsāgara and Pañcatantra traditions. Kukarm (whose name means 'wicked deed' — given by his ashamed grandparents) turns out to be a child of genius who exposes the queen's infidelity to the king by clever detective reasoning — whereupon the king executes the queen and her disguised male paramours, and Kukarm earns honour and fame.

Applied through Navya-Nyāya analysis: Kukarm's reasoning in the folktale is a perfect demonstration of anumāna (inference). He reasons from the visible evidence (two women who are actually men, exposed when they attempt to straddle a rope at his instruction) to the hidden truth (the queen's infidelity). This is Navya-Nyāya's inference structure: Vyāpti (invariable concomitance — cross-dressing males will be exposed by anatomical test), Pakṣa (the suspects), Sādhya (the hidden fact), Liṅga (the visible sign). Mandal intuitively deploys the epistemological structure of Gaṅgeśa's logical tradition in his narrative.

### *2.2.2 'Kisna Muṭṭī' — The Mela of the Fistful*

This micro-fiction is among Mandal's most poignant. Marani, a young girl, secretly sells a gourd from her family's field, hides the money, and plans her expenditure for the village fair (Kisna Muṭṭī mela) with loving precision: four annas each for her two younger sisters Abheliya and Sugiya; four annas for a puppet and a balloon for her little brother; four annas for kachori and chop for herself; eight annas for alta (red foot-dye) and ribbon for herself; and eight annas for jalebis for the return journey.

The mother discovers the sold gourd, assumes it was stolen money, and beats the girl before she can explain. The child weeps — 'Mā go māe, melā dekhailai jāeb melā — Kisna Muṭṭīk melā' — I want to go see the fair, the fair of Kisna Mutti.' This ending, withholding resolution and leaving the child's punishment and unexplained innocence in painful suspension, is a masterpiece of Dhvani — the unstated resonance is louder than anything stated. The fair (melā) becomes a symbol of joy denied, of childhood aspiration crushed by adult assumption of guilt.

The story demonstrates Mandal's mastery of the Bīhani Kathā (seed story) form — the tiny narrative that contains the seed of a much larger social truth: the poverty that forces children to secret economies, the adult violence that

misreads innocence as theft, the festivals that are both aspiration and heartbreak for the rural poor.

## 2.3 Critical Reviews and Literary Essays

### *2.3.1 Reviews of Jagdish Prasad Mandal's Novels*

The Sanchiyka contains substantial reviews of two novels by Jagdish Prasad Mandal: Jīvan-Saṃgharṣa (Life-Struggle) and Jīvan-Maraṇa (Life-Death). These reviews are significant both for their critical substance and for what they reveal about Durganand Mandal's own literary values.

In his review of Jīvan-Saṃgharṣa, Mandal argues that the novel is not fantasy but is based on hard reality (yathārtha). He identifies several themes: the rape of a young woman at a Durga Puja fair (structural violence against women in public spaces); the collective response of the village (social solidarity vs. individual revenge); the counter-institution of Kali Puja as a rival festival to the offending Durga Puja; and the mobilisation of a multi-caste committee for community governance. His critical method is essentially sociological — he reads the novel as a document of social processes, aligning with Lukács's theory of the 'type' as a crystallisation of social forces.

In his review of Jīvan-Maraṇa, Mandal praises the novel's treatment of the tension between 'Western civilisation's uncivilised influence' on the younger generation and the traditional Maithili joint-family social culture. He particularly appreciates the portrait of Subhadra — the 111-year-old elder — and her relationship with the protagonist's father's old cow. These marginal social details (the aged woman, the ageing animal) are, for Mandal, precisely the carriers of the novel's deepest meaning — a reading consistent with the Dhvani theory's emphasis on peripheral detail as the site of resonance.

### *2.3.2 Review of Bechan Thakur's Play 'Beṭīk Apmānpar ek Najari'*

Durganand Mandal's review of Bechan Thakur's play on the dishonour done to daughters ('Beṭīk apmān āo chīnardevī') is a significant critical document. Mandal begins with an indictment of the neglect of Maithili drama as a genre — 'Maithili nāṭak has always been like a one-day rain: isolated, not sustained.' He then turns to the specific social crisis that Thakur's play addresses: the declining sex ratio (more boys than girls) in contemporary India, and the practice of female foeticide.

Mandal's critical argument is passionate and rhetorically structured. He invokes historical women of achievement — Rani Jhansi, Savitri, Ahilya, Indira

Gandhi, Madam Curie, Mother Teresa — to argue that daughters have been the architects of history and society. He then makes the crucial logical point: if these women had been killed in the womb, what would today look like? The argument is implicitly a Navya-Nyāya counterfactual inference: if X (daughter) had not existed, Y (historical achievement) would not have occurred; therefore the destruction of X is the destruction of Y.

He also credits Jagdish Prasad Mandal's inspirational influence on Bechan Thakur — noting that Thakur writes from within the parallel tradition — and thanks both Shruti Prakashan and Videha for enabling the publication and promotion of this work. This network of acknowledgements reveals the social and institutional ecology of the parallel literary movement.

### *2.3.3 Reviews of Children's Illustrated Books (Prīti Ṭhākur's Citrkathas)*

Among the most charming and revealing items in the Sanchiyka are Mandal's reviews of two illustrated children's books by Priti Thakur — one on Gonu Jha (the famous Maithili folk wit) and one a general Maithili children's illustrated book. These reviews reveal Mandal's deep engagement with Maithili folk tradition, children's literature, and the politics of cultural preservation.

He notes that the Maithili characters illustrated — Reshma-Chuharmul (a tragic inter-caste love story; Chuharmul is Dusadh caste, Reshma is Bhumihar Brahmin), Naika-Banjara, Jyoti Panjiyar, Mahua Ghatvarin, Raja Salhes, Chhechhan Maharaj, Kalidasa — represent 'all castes of society' (prāyaḥ sabhā jāitik lok). He specifically notes that Priti Thakur has documented that Kalidasa was born in the Yadav (cowherd caste) community — a fact suppressed by those who claimed him as Karna-Kayastha. This act of caste-corrective literary history is exactly the work the Videha Parallel History Framework performs at the macro level.

The review of the Reshma-Chuharmul illustration is particularly telling: Mandal argues that Reshma and Chuharmul's love — divided by the Brahmin-Dusadh caste boundary — represents a love no less pure than Heer-Ranjha or Laila-Majnun. 'Love is not made; it happens by itself (prem kayal nahi jai, apane bha jai).' This egalitarian theory of love is simultaneously a critique of the caste system and an aesthetic claim: the highest human emotion transcends social hierarchy.

## 2.4 Social and Political Essays

### *2.4.1 Independence Day Essay: 'Swatantrā Divas par Kichu Swatantra Bhārās'*

This essay — 'Some Independent Thoughts on Independence Day' — is Mandal's most explicitly political writing and demonstrates his range beyond creative fiction. It is a scathing critique of official Independence Day ceremonies: the khadi-clad politicians who give hypocritical speeches before the national flag while practising corruption throughout the year. The essay is structured as a sustained indictment: 'We have been listening to false speeches for fifty years... now listening to falsehoods while making others like us listen to them — how bad a thing this is!'

The essay identifies specific corruptions: the government officials who dress in khadi for the occasion but engage in bribery and exploitation the remaining 364 days; the politicians who deposit national wealth in foreign accounts; the systematic dishonesty of the political class. It ends with a call to awakening: 'Wake up, wake up, O son of India, wake up now.' The rhetoric is in the Gandhian tradition of moral exhortation, but the content is a democratic socialist critique of the post-colonial Indian state.

The essay is also titled 'Buṛhiyā Phūsiyā' (Old Woman's Lies) in another version in the Sanchiyka — an extended satirical meditation on the culture of official lying that pervades Indian institutional life. Mandal argues that lying has become a hereditary practice (putainī jhūṭhā — ancestral liars), and that every national holiday has become an occasion for the ritual performance of falsehood. The satire is biting and original.

### *2.4.2 Essay on Rākhi (Raksha Bandhan)*

Mandal's essay on the festival of Raksha Bandhan — addressed to 'all Maithils' from Godhanapur, Nirmal — is a thoughtful meditation on the festival's meaning in the context of contemporary gender violence. He moves from the historical meaning of the festival (a sister tying a protective thread on her brother's wrist, even across the Hindu-Muslim boundary during medieval conflicts) to its contemporary crisis (the systematic violation of women's safety despite the Rakhi covenant).

His argument is both feminist and spiritual: 'To purify this polluted tendency, sight, and action, one must remain pure in mind, speech, and deed, and treat everyone as one's own sister.' He appeals to the 'Param Piṭā Paramātmā' (Supreme Father, Universal Soul) — the language of his Brahmo-inspired

universalism — to argue that before the Divine there is no distinction of man and woman, and that this should be the basis of social relations. The essay concludes with a call for an 'ātmīk rākhī' — a soul-bond — that goes deeper than the physical ceremony.

# III. Critical Frameworks and Theoretical Analysis

## 3.1 Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya

### *3.1.1 Gaṅgeśa and the Suppressed Democratic Tradition*

The Videha Parallel History Framework makes a foundational claim about Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (c. 13th-14th century, Mithila) — the founder of Navya-Nyāya (New Logic) and author of the Tattvacintāmaṇi — that has direct bearing on the reading of Durganand Mandal. The Videha research, based on Dūṣaṇa Pañji (genealogical records), reveals that Gaṅgeśa was born of an inter-caste union — his mother was a Charmakāriṇī (of the leather-tanning community) — and that this fact was systematically suppressed by the upper-caste literary establishment, most notably by the scholar Ramanath Jha, who concealed it from historian Dinesh Chandra Bhattacharya.

This biographical correction is not merely biographical: it establishes that the founder of Navya-Nyāya — India's most rigorous epistemological school — was himself a product of the suppressed non-Brahmin tradition of Mithila. Gaṅgeśa's work thus belongs, by the logic of the Parallel History, to the same democratic counter-tradition to which Durganand Mandal belongs. Reading Mandal through Gaṅgeśa is not an imposition of an alien theoretical framework but a recovery of a shared subaltern intellectual heritage.

### *3.1.2 Pramāṇa Theory and Literary Knowledge*

Gaṅgeśa's epistemology identifies four Pramāṇas (sources of valid knowledge): Pratyakṣa (perception), Anumāna (inference), Upamāna (comparison/analogy), and Śabda (testimony/verbal knowledge). Each has application to the reading of Mandal's literary practice.

Mandal's stories function primarily as Pratyakṣa — direct perception of social reality. His dense, specific descriptions of village life — the toddy shop, the Holi songs, the seasonal rhythms of agricultural Mithila, the texture of food and festival — constitute a form of literary perception that enables the reader to 'see' (the title of his collection Chakshu — 'The Eye') what would otherwise remain invisible to those outside the community. This is Mandal's first epistemological function: making visible what is structurally rendered invisible.

His critical essays function as Anumāna — inference from visible signs to hidden structural truths. When he argues, in his Independence Day essay, from

the observable behaviour of politicians (khadi clothing, flag-saluting, corrupt actions) to the hidden reality (the systematic dishonesty of the post-colonial state), he is performing precisely the Navya-Nyāya logical operation: from the Liṅga (visible sign) to the Sādhya (hidden conclusion) via the Vyāpti (the invariable rule that connects them).

The Navya-Nyāya concept of Pakṣatā — the subjective condition of inquiry, the living doubt that drives the search for knowledge — illuminates Mandal's position as a writer. He writes from a position of profound pakṣatā: the unresolved social contradictions of rural Bihar (caste oppression, gender violence, migrant exploitation, superstition, educational aspiration) constitute the practical lived uncertainty that his writing seeks to resolve. His writing is not decorative but epistemologically driven.

Finally, the concept of Anuvyavasāya (meta-cognition — the awareness of one's own knowing) is enacted in the Sanchiyka's interview, where Mandal reflects explicitly on his own literary practice: his theory of the word, his philosophy of storytelling, his analysis of the structural conditions of non-Brahmin writing. This reflexive meta-critical dimension makes the Sanchiyka not merely a creative collection but an epistemological document — a record of a writer's awareness of how he knows and why he writes.

## 3.2 Bharata's Nāṭyaśāstra and Indian Classical Aesthetics

### *3.2.1 Rasa Theory Applied to Mandal's Fiction*

Bharata's Nāṭyaśāstra identifies eight primary Rasas (aesthetic emotions): Śṛṅgāra (love/beauty), Hāsya (humour), Karuṇa (compassion/pathos), Raudra (fury), Vīra (heroism), Bhayānaka (terror), Bībhatsa (disgust), and Adbhuta (wonder). Abhinavagupta added Śānta (tranquility) as a ninth.

Mandal's fiction is predominantly Karuṇa-rasa — the rasa of compassion, sorrow, and pathos — activated by the depiction of structural suffering: the girl denied access to a fair (Kisna Muṭṭī), the poor doctor whose hunger goes unaddressed (Karmaveer's early years), the young woman whose pregnancy results from accidental consumption of a skull-powder misidentified as poison (Kukarm). Yet his satire activates Hāsya-rasa (in Baklel), his romantic stories activate Śṛṅgāra-rasa (in Lal Bhouji and Paras), and his political essays activate Raudra-rasa (the fury of the Independence Day satire and the Rakhi essay on gender violence).

The Nāṭyaśāstra's theory of Vibhāva (excitants), Anubhāva (consequent expressions), and Vyabhicāribhāva (transient emotional states) is particularly

illuminating for Mandal's story craft. In 'Kisna Muṭṭī,' the Vibhāvas are the poverty of the family, the child's secret economic initiative, the mother's misidentification, and the beating. The Anubhāvas are the child's weeping and the repeated cry for the fair. The Vyabhicāribhāvas — the child's excited planning, her careful budgeting, her loving allocation of gifts for each sibling — create the emotional complexity (joy turning to pain) that constitutes the story's Karuṇa-rasa achievement.

### *3.2.2 Dhvani Theory: The Resonant Unsaid*

Ānandavardhana's Dhvanyāloka (9th century) argues that the highest poetry achieves its effect through Dhvani — resonance, the unstated meaning that vibrates beyond the literal. Applied to Mandal's micro-fiction, this framework is exact. The ending of 'Kisna Muṭṭī' — the child's cry for the fair — says nothing about poverty, nothing about maternal violence, nothing about structural inequality. Yet all of these resonate in the space between the literal words and the reader's understanding.

Similarly, the ending of Karmaveer's early hunger — sleeping without food, burning with ambition, unable to tell anyone — does not editorialize. The restraint is the Dhvani. The 'hollow eyes and hungry belly' of the young Karmaveer are not interpreted for us; they resonate. This is Mandal's most significant aesthetic achievement: a narrative restraint that generates maximum emotional and social resonance through minimum statement.

Abhinavagupta's concept of the Sahṛdaya (the sensitive reader, literally 'one with the same heart') is relevant here: Mandal's Dhvani is accessible only to readers who share the cultural and social coordinates of rural Maithili life — who know what a Kisna Mutti mela means, who know the Holi songs, who know the toddy-shop culture. The Sahṛdaya is, in the first instance, the community from which the writer emerges.

### *3.2.3 Kuntaka's Vakrokti and Mandal's Satirical Idiom*

Kuntaka's Vakroktijīvita (10th-11th century Kashmir) argues that the essence of literary language is Vakrokti — oblique speech, the deviated expression that says something indirectly, with a twist. Mandal's satirical essays, particularly 'Buṛhiyā Phūsiyā' and the Independence Day essay, deploy Vakrokti systematically: the politician dressed in khadi who lies before the national flag is not directly condemned but described with precise irony, allowing the reader to draw the conclusion. This is exactly Kuntaka's point: the best literary

expression achieves its effect through obliqueness, not through direct statement.

## 3.3 The Videha Parallel History Framework

### *3.3.1 The Democratic Literary Tradition*

The Videha Parallel History Framework, developed by Gajendra Thakur through the Videha eJournal (www.videha.co.in, ISSN 2229-547X), constitutes the indispensable critical context for Durganand Mandal's work. The Framework argues that Maithili literary history as institutionally constructed (primarily by the Sahitya Akademi, Delhi, and the Maithili Akademi, Patna) has systematically promoted an upper-caste canon — overwhelmingly Maithil Brahmin and Karna-Kayastha — while suppressing democratic, folk, Dalit, feminist, and Nepal-side traditions.

Durganand Mandal belongs unambiguously to the suppressed parallel tradition. He is non-Brahmin, village-based, employed as a government school teacher, writing in the everyday vocabulary of the rural OBC community. He began writing through the encouragement of Jagdish Prasad Mandal — himself the exemplary figure of the parallel tradition's democratic novelistic practice. He publishes in Videha — the digital counter-institution that has created, in the words of the Parallel History, 'a million pages of Maithili corpus' outside the institutional channels.

The Parallel History explicitly documents the RTI (Right to Information) findings of Vinit Utpal and Ashish Anchinhar (2011-14): over 90% of Sahitya Akademi translation and publication assignments went to friends and relatives of the ten-member advisory board. This means that writers like Durganand Mandal — who have no institutional connections to the Brahmin-Kayastha literary establishment — are systematically excluded not only from recognition but from the material support (translation commissions, publication grants) that sustains literary careers.

### *3.3.2 The Bīhani Kathā Tradition*

The Videha Parallel History (Part 32) specifically documents the Bīhani Kathā (seed story/morning story) tradition as a distinctive Maithili literary form with deep roots in the oral tradition of Mithila. Mandal's micro-fictions — 'Kukarm,' 'Kisna Muṭṭī,' the two pieces titled 'Postmortem' and 'Pollution' at the end of the Sanchiyka — belong explicitly to this tradition. They are compressed narratives that plant seeds of social meaning without exhausting them.

The two closing micro-fictions are particularly instructive: 'Postmortem' (about a school principal who is beaten by his students after refusing to teach, and whose parent meeting reveals the dynamics of accountability in rural education) and 'Pollution' (about internal moral pollution in a society that prioritises material comfort over human connection) represent the Bīhani Kathā at its most concentrated. Each story is barely a paragraph, yet each contains the seed of a major social analysis.

## 3.4 Western Critical Frameworks

### *3.4.1 Marxist Literary Theory and Social Realism*

Georg Lukács's theory of the 'type' — the literary character who crystallises a social position, embodying both individual psychology and social forces — is directly applicable to Mandal's fiction. Karmaveer is not merely an individual doctor: he is a 'type' of the educated non-Brahmin village youth who aspires to serve his community without migrating to the city. The toddy-drinkers in the village chowk are not merely colourful background figures: they crystallise the social conditions (poverty, underemployment, lack of alternatives) that produce their behaviour.

Raymond Williams's concept of the 'structure of feeling' — the affective texture of a specific historical moment, not yet fully articulated in formal ideology — is illuminated by Mandal's fiction. His stories capture the structure of feeling of early twenty-first century rural Bihar: the simultaneous presence of aspirational mobility (education, government jobs, medicine) and structural stasis (caste discrimination, gender violence, flood displacement, educational neglect). This is not a structure that can be fully articulated in political discourse; it requires the oblique, sensory language of narrative fiction.

Fredric Jameson's concept of the 'political unconscious' — the claim that all literature is ultimately a symbolic resolution of social contradictions — is instructive for reading Mandal's fictions of social mobility (Paras, Karmaveer). These narratives resolve, at the level of fiction, contradictions that cannot be resolved in social reality: the brilliant non-Brahmin student who succeeds despite systemic barriers. This is not naive optimism but what Jameson calls the 'Utopian horizon' of social fiction — the imagined resolution that keeps social aspiration alive.

### *3.4.2 New Historicism and the Document of Culture*

Stephen Greenblatt's New Historicism insists that literary texts are embedded in specific historical moments and that they contain within them traces of the social negotiation and conflict that produced them. Mandal's Sanchiyka is an unusually self-aware instance of this: it explicitly dates several of its items (the 2003 Koshi bridge story, the 2012 Tagore Literature Award journey), it names specific places (Nirmal, Jhitki, Godhanapur, Madhubani), and it situates itself within the specific institutional ecology of Videha, Shruti Prakashan, and the parallel literary movement.

The account of Jagdish Prasad Mandal's receipt of the Tagore Literature Award in Kochi (2012) — narrated by Durganand Mandal who accompanied him — is a remarkable cultural document. It records in vivid detail the journey from the Maithili village Berma (Madhubani) to Patna by bus, then by air to Kochi; the five-star hotel; the Samsung-sponsored award ceremony; the Tamil dancer Padma Shri Shobhana Chandrakumar's performance; the seven languages honoured. This narrative of a non-Brahmin Maithili village novelist receiving an international literary award in a southern Indian city — watched by a companion who is himself a village schoolteacher-writer — is the Parallel History of Maithili literature enacted in real time.

### *3.4.3 Postcolonial Theory and the Subaltern Voice*

Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's foundational question — 'Can the subaltern speak?' — and her argument that the subaltern is systematically denied the conditions of speech within the colonial and postcolonial order — is directly applicable to Mandal's literary project. The non-Brahmin writer in Maithili faces a specific version of this silencing: the literary language itself has been constructed in a way that excludes his community's vocabulary and registers, making the very act of writing in 'standard' Maithili an act of self-alienation.

Mandal's response is to write in the everyday language of his community — the register of the OBC village schoolteacher — without apology or mediation. His stories are written in a Maithili that is recognisable to his community, not the Sanskrit-inflected literary Maithili of the Brahmin tradition. This is what Homi Bhabha would call 'the third space' — the site where subaltern cultural expression creates its own norms and conventions outside the dominant cultural framework.

## 3.5 Performance and Oral Theory

Mandal's theory of storytelling — expressed in the Munnaji interview — is explicitly a performance theory. He speaks of reading aloud (katha pāṭha), of illuminating each word for the listener's existence, of the pleasure (ānanda) that the listener experiences through hearing. This connects his work to the oral performance traditions of Mithila — the Dāstāngoi (professional storytelling), the Pāthārambha (public reading), the village gathering around the storyteller.

The Walter Ong/Jack Goody oral-literary continuum is relevant here: Mandal's writing retains the characteristics of primary orality — the formulaic description of characters (nāyikāvarnana), the repetition of key phrases, the direct address to the audience — even in its written form. His work is best understood as lying at the interface between oral and literate culture — a transitional literature that is reshaping Maithili prose in the direction of the spoken, the democratic, the accessible.

# IV. Thematic and Ideological Analysis

## 4.1 The Village as Literary Universe

Every piece in Mandal's corpus is rooted in the Maithili village. Unlike the migration-narrative that dominates much contemporary Indian writing (the rural person who goes to the city and is transformed), Mandal's literary universe insists that the village contains sufficient material for a full human life. His narrator in 'Karmaveer' makes this explicit: 'In the soil and water of the village there is every happiness.' This is not naive ruralism but a political claim: that the aspiration to city life is partly a socially constructed dissatisfaction, and that the development of the village — through people like Karmaveer who choose to stay — is both possible and necessary.

This village-rootedness connects Mandal to the Maithili folk tradition (which is overwhelmingly rural), to the social-realist novelistic tradition of Jagdish Prasad Mandal (whose novels are all rooted in Madhubani villages), and to the political tradition of Gandhian gram-swaraj (village self-rule). It also connects him to the global tradition of magical and social realism's recovery of the local — Garcia Marquez's Macondo, Hardy's Wessex, Premchand's rural UP.

## 4.2 Caste, Community, and Democratic Aspiration

Caste is the invisible structural force that shapes every dimension of Mandal's literary world. It is rarely named directly in the fiction — but it is always present as the unseen organiser of social possibility and constraint. Karmaveer's hunger and poverty are the poverty of a non-Brahmin village family in early twenty-first century Bihar. Paras's tea-selling — his lack of access to the patronage networks that smooth the paths of upper-caste youth — is the condition of non-Brahmin educational aspiration. The 'line that is hard to cross' that Mandal describes in his interview is the caste line.

Yet Mandal's response to caste is not separatism or militancy but democratic aspiration — the demand for inclusion in a common Maithili literary culture, on equal terms. His reviews of Priti Thakur's children's books celebrate precisely the multi-caste representation in Maithili folk narrative: Reshma-Chuharmul's inter-caste love, Raja Salhes's low-caste heroism, Kalidasa's Yadav origins. This is the democratic vision: a Maithili literature that includes all communities, not as exotica but as full human subjects.

## 4.3 Gender and Domestic Life

Mandal's treatment of gender is complex and sometimes contradictory. His satire of the dependent husband (Baklel) is feminist in effect — exposing male helplessness disguised as love. His Rakhi essay is explicitly feminist in argument — calling for genuine protection of women's safety rather than ceremonial protection. His story 'Paras' ends with girls identifying with a male protagonist's aspiration to self-improvement.

Yet his fiction also contains extensive nāyikāvarnana (heroine-description) passages that deploy the male gaze of the Sanskrit aesthetic tradition — detailed physical description of women from the perspective of a male narrator/protagonist. These passages are both part of the Maithili literary tradition Mandal inhabits and a site of tension with his democratic aspirations. A feminist reading of this tension would note that Mandal's work is not exempt from the gender contradictions of its social context, even as it works to critique many aspects of that context.

## 4.4 Education, Knowledge, and Social Mobility

Education — its acquisition, its value, and its social implications — is the central thematic obsession of Mandal's fiction. Paras studies while selling tea. Karmaveer studies while struggling against poverty. The girls in Mandal's class aspire to become 'Paras.' The Independence Day essay implies that genuine education — as opposed to the ritual lip-service of official ceremonies — is the only path to genuine freedom.

This obsession with education is not surprising in a writer who is himself a schoolteacher — but it goes deeper than professional interest. For Mandal, as for the democratic tradition he inhabits, education is the primary instrument of social emancipation: not in the Macaulayite sense (education in English to produce colonial administrators) but in the Ambedkarite sense (education as the acquisition of knowledge, critical thinking, and social dignity).

# V. Literary Significance and Critical Evaluation

## 5.1 Contribution to Maithili Literature

Durganand Mandal's contribution to Maithili literature is significant on several dimensions. First, he has produced work across multiple genres — short story, micro-fiction, critical review, social essay, poem — demonstrating versatility and commitment to the literary enterprise that goes beyond a single form. Second, he has introduced into Maithili fiction the vocabulary, concerns, and social textures of the OBC rural community — a community that has been structurally excluded from the literary register of 'standard' Maithili. Third, his critical reviews and literary essays have contributed to the development of a democratic Maithili literary criticism that reads texts from below, for their social content and ethical implications, rather than primarily for their aesthetic adherence to classical standards.

His work in the Bīhani Kathā form — particularly 'Kisna Muṭṭī' and the two closing pieces in the Sanchiyka — represents a genuine achievement in the micro-fiction genre. The compression, the restraint, and the resonant ending of 'Kisna Muṭṭī' in particular stands comparison with the finest examples of the form in Maithili literature.

## 5.2 Relationship to the Parallel Tradition

Mandal is a second-generation figure of the parallel literary tradition that Videha has documented and promoted. His mentor Jagdish Prasad Mandal is a first-generation figure — the foundational Maithili novelist of the parallel tradition. Durganand Mandal represents the reproduction and expansion of this tradition: a younger writer who has absorbed its values and practices and is extending them into new formal territories (critical review, social essay) and new thematic domains (pharmaceutical exploitation, educational aspiration, Holi folk culture).

His close relationship with Videha — as both a contributor and a reader who credits the journal with transforming his understanding of Maithili linguistic possibility — makes him an embodiment of what the Parallel History identifies as the Videha Era's central achievement: the creation of a digital counter-institution that enables non-Brahmin, village-based writers to publish, circulate, and reach readers outside the institutional channels of the Sahitya Akademi network.

## 5.3 Limitations and Areas for Further Research

The critical appreciation offered here is necessarily preliminary. The full archive of Mandal's contributions to Videha — spanning multiple issues from 2009 to the present — requires systematic documentation and analysis. The novel-form work, if any, that may be in progress or unpublished requires investigation. The performance dimension of his storytelling practice — his oral presentations at katha-goshthi events — deserves documentation and analysis through performance studies frameworks.

Additionally, a comparative analysis of Mandal's work alongside other second-generation parallel tradition writers — Munnaji (Manojkumar Karn), Ashish Anchinhar, and others named in the Videha Parallel History — would help situate his particular contribution within the broader democratic literary movement.

## VI. Conclusion: The Eye That Sees

The title of one of Durganand Mandal's collections — Chakshu, The Eye — encapsulates his literary project. He is a writer who sees: who refuses the selective blindness of institutional Maithili literature, who looks at the village chowk (with its toddy shop and paan stall and festival songs) and finds in it the full complexity of human life; who looks at the non-Brahmin writer's structural situation and names it without bitterness; who looks at the female foeticide crisis and demands accountability; who looks at the corruption of Independence Day celebrations and names the hypocrisy.

This eye — trained by lived experience, sharpened by the literary tradition of Videha and Jagdish Prasad Mandal, and guided by the democratic values of the parallel literary movement — is the instrument of a genuine literary intelligence. Mandal's work may not yet have achieved the formal completion of his mentor's novels, but in its range, its social commitment, its linguistic vitality, and its epistemological honesty, it constitutes a body of work that the criticism of Maithili literature cannot afford to ignore.

The Navya-Nyāya concept that is most fitting as a final framework for Mandal's work is Vyāpti — invariable concomitance, the rule that connects the sign to the conclusion. Mandal's literary practice establishes, through accumulated particular instances, the following vyāptis: wherever there is a village, there is sufficient material for a full human life; wherever there is a non-Brahmin writer, there is a perspective that the dominant tradition cannot accommodate; wherever there is the suppressed word (from the OBC community's everyday vocabulary), there is literary power waiting to be released. These are the invariable rules that his writing, case by case, story by story, demonstrates.

*"Sabhā jāitik lok, cāhe o Brahmin ho vā Dom — sabhak apan bhūmikā hoit chhaikak. Jihiṇā phulavāṛīme sabhā phul raihet achhik, tihiṇā samājho ekaṭā phulavāṛī hoit chhaikak."* **— Durganand Mandal, review of Jagdish Prasad Mandal's Jīvan-Maraṇa**

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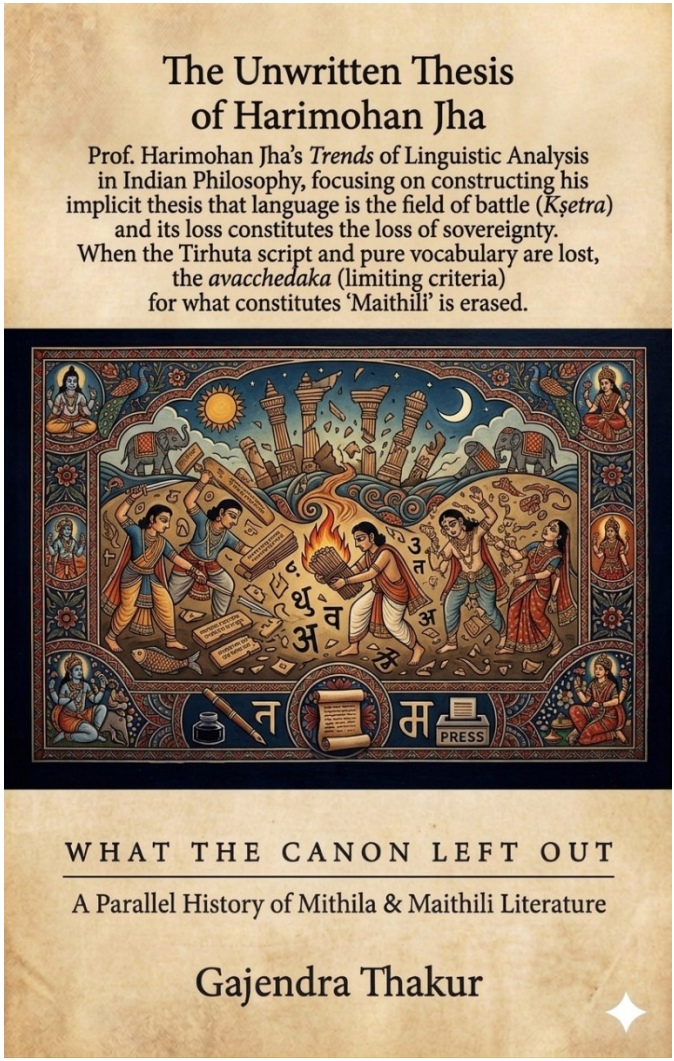
**LESSON 024 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**



# The Unwritten Thesis of Harimohan Jha When the Tirhuta script and pure vocabulary are lost, the avacchedaka (limiting criteria) for what constitutes 'Maithili' is erased.

Prof. Harimohan Jha's Trends of Linguistic Analysis in Indian Philosophy, focusing on constructing his implicit thesis that language is the field of battle (Kṣetra) and its loss constitutes the loss of sovereignty

While Prof. Harimohan Jha’s Trends of Linguistic Analysis in Indian Philosophy (1981) is ostensibly a scholarly survey of Sanskrit semantics (Sphota, Nyaya, Mimamsa), a deep reading reveals a potent subtext. Jha, a philosopher fluent in both the Navya Nyaya logical framework and the lived reality of colonial India, posits language not merely as a tool for communication, but as the very Kṣetra (field/terrain) of cognitive sovereignty.

This analysis argues that within Jha’s framework, the loss of linguistic precision is the loss of the kingdom. Drawing parallels between the metaphysical battles of Indian philosophy and the political reality of mid-20th century India, Jha demonstrates that to lose control over the analysis of Sabda (word) is to lose the ability to define reality, adjudicate disputes, and ultimately, govern.

1. The Metaphysical Battlefield: Why Grammar is War
Jha’s work opens not with syntax, but with the Sphotavada—the theory of the "unfolding" of meaning . He traces the concept of Sabda Brahman (Word-God), citing the Bhagavata Purana which describes it as durvigahyam samudravat—an ocean as difficult to cross as it is to comprehend .

For Jha, the ancient debates between the Vaiyakaranas (Grammarians) and the Naiyayikas (Logicians) are not academic quibbles; they are strategic battles for control of reality.

School of Thought Linguistic Stance Geopolitical Corollary
Mimamsa (Varṇavāda) Letters (varna) are the eternal units of meaning.

Conservatism: The law is in the letter. To control the alphabet is to control the scripture.
Nyaya (Padavāda) The word (pada) is the real unit; letters are evanescent. Pragmatism: The unit of diplomacy is the articulated concept, not the sound.
Vaiyakaranas (Vakyavada) The sentence (vakya) is an indivisible whole (Akhanda). Idealism/Holism: The "State" or "Nation" is a synthetic whole greater than the sum of its parts.
Jha highlights the Akhandavakyavada—the theory that a sentence is an indivisible unit [citation:26]. This is a direct challenge to Western phonetic alphabetic logic. If a sentence is a Gestalt (whole), then meaning cannot be broken down into atomic "letters" without destroying it. In the context of colonialism, this suggests that translating a culture's core propositions (its Vakyas) into a foreign tongue destroys the original meaning entirely.

2. Navya Nyaya: The Technology of Precision
The most "weaponized" chapter in the text is Jha's exposition of Navya Nyaya [citation:142]. He does not just explain Avacchedakata (limitors/qualifiers); he presents it as a scalpel.

Jha demonstrates that the Navya Nyaya formula—breaking knowledge down into Viśeṣyatā (substantivity), Prakāratā (adjectivity), and Saṃsargatā (relationship)—is designed to eliminate ambiguity [citation:147].

The "Russell" Connection:
Jha performs a radical act of comparative philosophy by taking Bertrand Russell's famous analytic proposition, "Scott is the author of Waverley," and translating it into the Navya Nyaya idiom [citation:166].

Western Logic breaks this into existence and uniqueness clauses ( "At least one... at most one..." ).

Navya Nyaya breaks it into a web of ontological relations (Scott-ness, Act-ness, Book-ness).

Jha's Implication: By showing that Navya Nyaya can not only translate but potentially surpass the precision of Russell's "Mathematical Philosophy," Jha reclaims intellectual sovereignty. He argues that India did not need the West to teach it how to analyze language; it had a native technology that could cut reality at its joints with surgical precision.

3. Negation (Abhava) and the Politics of "No"
One of the most striking sections of the book is Jha's analysis of Negation (Abhava) [citation:172]. He demonstrates how a simple negative proposition —"The pot is not on the ground"—can yield eight different meanings depending on the Avacchedaka (specificity of time, space, and relation) [citation:180].

"The pot is not on the ground by relation of inherence" vs. "The pot is not on this ground by contact."

In the context of Jha's life (writing post-Independence), this is a treatise on jurisprudence and sovereignty. A vague "No" loses the kingdom; a specific "No" holds it.

To rule is to negate (to prohibit, to deny, to reject). Jha provides the tools for a Rajyābhidhā (Science of State Language). If a legal document states, "There is no pot on the ground," without specifying which pot, which ground, or which relation, the statement is logically useless. Jha argues that for a linguistic act (like a law or a treaty) to be binding, the Abhava must be precisely avacchinna (limited/specified).

4. Sabda as Pramana: The Authority of the Word
Jha traces the concept of Sabda Pramana—the Word as a valid means of knowledge [citation:94]. In Indian logic, the testimony of a reliable person (Apta Vakya) is a legitimate source of truth, independent of perception or inference.

Jha quotes the classic definition: an Apta is one who speaks yathartha (as it is) and is incapable of deceit [citation:96].

The Post-Colonial Reading:
In a colonial structure, the colonizer claims the right to be the Apta—the "reliable source" who defines the native. By re-asserting Sabda Pramana, Jha argues that the Indian philosophical tradition already possesses a rigorous epistemology of testimony. One does not need Western "verification" to validate a statement if it comes from a proper Apta. Jha creates a defense mechanism against epistemic violence: the colonizer's word is not Pramana (valid knowledge) because it lacks Yogyata (fitness/compatibility) with the

reality of the land.

5. The Novelist as Philosopher: The Loss of Vak
It is crucial to remember that Jha was not just a philosopher; he was a celebrated novelist in Maithili, author of Kanyadan (The Bride) . He won the Sahitya Akademi Award for his autobiography, Jeevan Yatra .

Jha saw the death of a language as the death of a universe.

Loss of Akānkṣā (Expectancy): When a language dies, the culture loses the inherent expectancy that links one word to another, one generation to the next.

Loss of Yogyatā (Fitness): Colonial education created a Yogyata crisis—where traditional concepts (like Dharma) no longer seemed "fit" to reside in the English sentence.

By writing philosophy in English (with extensive Sanskrit transliteration), Jha was performing a rescue operation. He was forcing the colonizer’s language to accommodate the Avacchedakas of Sanskrit.

Conclusion: The Kṣetra of the Mind
For Prof. Harimohan Jha, the "Trends of Linguistic Analysis" reveal a fundamental truth: Sovereignty begins in the Vak (speech).

In his framework:

Language is Territory: The Sabda Brahman is the infinite ocean of reality.

Grammar is Strategy: Navya Nyaya is the martial art of precise thought, capable of disarming fallacies.

Translation is Warfare: To translate Akhanda Vakya (indivisible sentences) into a foreign tongue without loss is the ultimate challenge of decolonization.

Jha’s great contribution is the application of Gadādhara’s Viśeṣaṇa-Viśeṣya-bhāva (Qualifier-Qualificand relation) to history. He argues that the colonizer attempted to turn the colonized into a mere Viśeṣaṇa (adjective/quality) of the British Empire. By resurrecting the Viśeṣyatā (substantivity) of the Indian philosophical tradition, Jha declared: We are not a predicate of your history; we

are the subject of our own.

**The Linguistic Kṣetra: Prof. Harimohan Jha's Framework of Semantic Sovereignty and the Metaphysics of the Word**

The intellectual architecture of Prof. Harimohan Jha, particularly as articulated in his magnum opus, *Trends of Linguistic Analysis in Indian Philosophy*, establishes a profound and often overlooked nexus between the precision of linguistic categories and the maintenance of cultural and intellectual sovereignty. To Jha, language is not merely a descriptive tool but a *Kṣetra*—a field of battle—where the boundaries of reality, authority, and truth are contested and defined. His central thesis, which ripples through his academic treatises and his Maithili satirical works, suggests that the "loss of language"—understood as the erosion of semantic precision and the forgetting of logical delimiters—is synonymous with the "loss of kingdom," a total collapse of the cognitive and social structures that sustain a civilization. This report examines Jha's framework by synthesizing the classical Indian traditions of Vyākaraṇa, Nyāya, and Mimāṃsā with his unique Navya-Nyāya analytical techniques, demonstrating how the "Word" serves as the ultimate sovereign in the human experience of the world.

**The Ontological Foundations of the Word as Sovereign**

The point of departure for any investigation into Jha's linguistic framework must be the deification of the word, a concept rooted in the Vedic and Upanishadic traditions. Jha observes that the *Śabda-Brahman* (Word-God) is described as the consciousness inherent in all living beings, manifesting through the dual vibrations of *Nāma* (name) and *Rūpa* (form). This primordial manifestation suggests that the phenomenal world is not an independent entity but is evolved from the same conscious energy that constitutes speech. In the Taittirīya Brāhmaṇa, the act of creation is a speech-act: the Creator speaks "Earth," and the earth comes into being. Consequently, the "kingdom" of reality is built upon a linguistic substrate. If the language becomes corrupted or lost, the substrate of reality itself begins to dissolve, leading to the "loss of kingdom."

Jha emphasizes that the mystery of human speech attracted Indian thinkers from the earliest times, leading to an analysis that was phonetic, etymological, syntactical, semantic, and metaphysical. This multidisciplinary approach ensures that language is understood as a holistic system. The *Kṣetra* of language is divided into four levels of speech, ranging from the transcendent to the manifest. These levels provide a hierarchical defense of meaning, where each deeper level provides the stability for the one above it.

### The Hierarchical Structure of Vāk (Speech)

The four levels of speech described by Jha—Parā, Paśyantī, Madhyamā, and Vaikharī—correspond to both states of consciousness and physical centers of energy known as *Cakras*. This alignment of language with the human body underscores the idea that linguistic sovereignty is an embodied experience. When these levels are in harmony, the "kingdom" of the self and the "kingdom" of the state are secure.

| Level of Speech | Cognitive State | Physiological Locus (Cakra) | Function in the Kṣetra |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Parā** | Transcendent | Mūlādhāra (Basic Plexus) | The motionless, undifferentiated root of all power. |
| **Paśyantī** | Subtle Perception | Nābhi (Navel/Svadhisthana) | The first vibration; accessible only to yogins. |
| **Madhyamā** | Ideational | Hṛdaya (Heart/Anahata) | The inner, silent speech associated with the |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | | intellect. |
| **Vaikharī** | Manifest | Kaṇṭha (Throat/Visuddha) | The articulate sound used in external communication. |

The erosion of the "kingdom" begins with the fragmentation of these levels. In Jha's view, modern discourse often operates solely at the level of *Vaikharī*—the gross, manifest sound—divorced from the ideational depth of *Madhyamā* and the transcendent grounding of *Parā*. This detachment makes the manifest word vulnerable to manipulation, as it no longer carries the weight of authentic consciousness. The "loss of language" here is the loss of the vertical integration of speech, leaving the speaker in a state of cognitive "homelessness" or loss of sovereignty over their own expression.

**The Battle of Linguistic Units: Sphota and the Unity of Meaning**

In the *Kṣetra* of linguistic analysis, a central conflict arises regarding the ultimate unit of language. Is it the letter (*Varṇa*), the word (*Pada*), or the sentence (*Vākya*)? This debate is not merely academic; it determines how we perceive the structure of truth. Jha analyzes the theory of *Sphota*—the eternal word-symbol—as the primary weapon in this debate.

The problem of linguistic unity stems from the evanescent nature of sound. As sounds are pronounced in succession, the preceding sound vanishes before the next is uttered. Jha asks how a whole can be formed out of parts that are never co-existent. The *Sphota* theory, primarily advocated by the Grammarians (*Vaiyākaraṇas*) like Bhartṛhari, posits that there is an indivisible, eternal word-essence that is revealed by the fleeting sounds but is not created by them. This *Sphota* is the true sovereign of meaning, remaining stable amidst the "battle" of passing syllables.

**Comparative Theories of Linguistic Units**

Jha provides a detailed comparison of the different schools of thought regarding these units, which can be viewed as different tactical approaches to the *Kṣetra* of meaning.

| School of Thought | Unit of Language | Underlying Philosophy | Implications for Sovereignty |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Mimāṃsā** | Varṇa (Letter) | Varṇavāda: Letters are eternal and partless. | Atomistic view; meaning arises from the sequence of fixed units. |
| **Nyāya** | Pada (Word) | Padavāda: The word is the unit that possesses potency (*Śakti*). | Relational view; meaning depends on the word-object convention. |
| **Vyākaraṇa** | Vākya (Sentence) | Vākyavāda: The sentence is the only indivisible, real unit. | Holistic view; words and letters are mere pedagogical fictions. |

Jha champions the *Akhaṇḍa-Vākya-Sphotavāda* (the theory of the indivisible sentence-sphota), arguing that meaning is an integral whole. The "loss of language" occurs when we reduce a holistic judgment to a mere collection of parts. When the "kingdom" of the sentence is broken into isolated words, the overarching intention (*Tātparya*) is lost. Jha compares this to an army where the

individual soldiers lose sight of the commander's grand strategy; while they may remain "words" or "letters," they no longer constitute a "sentence" or a "victory".

**The Navya-Nyāya Technique: Avacchedakatā as the Shield of Precision**

The most sophisticated layer of Jha's framework involves the application of Navya-Nyāya logic, a system he mastered and championed throughout his career. In his 1974 presidential address to the Indian Philosophical Congress, Jha demonstrated that the Navya-Nyāya technique of *Avacchedakatā* (delimitation) is the ultimate tool for resolving contradictions and specifying meaning with mathematical precision.

*Avacchedakatā* is the process of defining the exact boundaries of a property or relation. In the *Kṣetra* of debate, an opponent may attempt to overthrow a "kingdom" of truth by pointing out a contradiction. The Naiyāyika (logician) defends the truth by applying delimiters to show that the contradiction is only apparent. For instance, if one says "the pot is blue" and another says "the pot is not blue," both may be right if we specify the *Avacchedaka* (delimiter): the pot is blue *in its color* but not blue *in its taste*.

**The Language of Delimitation (Avacchedakatā-vāda)**

Jha elucidates that every cognitive event is composed of three elements: the substantive (*Viśeṣya*), the qualifier (*Prakāra*), and the relationship (*Saṃsarga*). The sovereignty of knowledge depends on correctly identifying these elements.

| **Logical Concept** | **Sanskrit Term** | **Function in Analysis** |
|---|---|---|
| **Substantivity** | Viśeṣyatā | The locus or "ground" of the knowledge. |
| **Qualitativeness** | Prakāratā | The property that resides in the substantive. |
| **Relationalit** | Saṃsargatā | The link |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **y** | | between the substantive and the qualifier. |
| **Delimitation** | Avacchedakatā | The specific boundary that fixes the other three. |

This technique allows for the clarification (*Pariṣkāra*) of propositions. Jha argues that without such clarification, language becomes "loose," allowing for the encroachment of falsehood. The "loss of kingdom" in the logical sense is the loss of *Avacchedakatā*- the loss of the ability to define exactly what one means and does not mean. When delimiters are lost, the "territory" of one's argument is easily invaded and occupied by an opponent's misinterpretation.

**The Kṣetra of Negation: Defending the Kingdom through Abhāva**

A crucial aspect of Jha's linguistic framework is the analysis of negation (*Abhāva* or *Niṣedha*). In the *Kṣetra* of reality, "what is not" is just as important as "what is". To maintain the sovereignty of a kingdom, one must know not only who the citizens are but also who are the "non-citizens" or enemies. Jha provides a comprehensive analysis of the different kinds of non-existence, showing how they function as essential categories of thought.

The Naiyāyikas argue that negation is a real entity that is perceived through the relationship of *Viśeṣaṇatā* (adjectivity). When we say "there is no pot on the ground," the "absence of the pot" is an adjective of the ground. Jha points out that a simple negative statement can have up to eight different meanings once we apply the Navya-Nyāya technique of analyzing the *Pratiyogitā* (counter-positiveness) and its delimiters.

**Taxonomy of Non-Existence (Abhāva)**

The classification of *Abhāva* serves as a defensive wall for the linguistic kingdom, preventing different types of "absence" from being confused.

| Type of Abhāva | Description | Role in Sovereignty |
|---|---|---|

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **Prāgabhāva** | Antecedent non-existence | Knowing the state before a "kingdom" or "word" is created. |
| **Pradhvaṃsābhāva** | Destructive non-existence | Recognizing the state after something has been destroyed. |
| **Atyantābhāva** | Absolute non-existence | Defining things that can never exist in a certain locus. |
| **Anyonyābhāva** | Mutual non-existence | Maintaining the distinct identity of two entities (e.g., A is not B). |

The "loss of language" occurs when these distinctions are blurred. If one cannot distinguish between a "temporary absence" and an "absolute impossibility," the strategic planning of the "kingdom" fails. Jha emphasizes that the cognition of non-existence (*Abhāva-jñāna*) requires a knowledge of the counter-positive (*Pratiyogī*); to know that there is no "peace" in the kingdom, one must first have a clear concept of what "peace" is. Thus, even in negation, the sovereignty of the "Word" remains paramount.

**The Rhetoric of the Battlefield: Lakṣaṇā and Vyañjanā**

Language as a *Kṣetra* is not limited to the cold precision of logic; it also involves the fluid dynamics of rhetoric and poetics. Jha analyzes the three

powers of a word: *Abhidhā* (literal meaning), *Lakṣaṇā* (figurative meaning), and *Vyañjanā* (suggested meaning).

In the context of power and sovereignty, *Vyañjanā* or *Dhvani* (suggestion) is perhaps the most potent. It allows a speaker to convey truths that may be dangerous to state literally, or to evoke aesthetic states (*Rasa*) that unify the people. Jha argues that poetic language is a "refined" form of speech where the "Word" attains its highest sovereignty by transcending its literal boundaries.

**The Tactical Uses of Figurative Language**

Jha provides a detailed breakdown of *Lakṣaṇā*, showing how it is used when the literal meaning (*Mukhyārtha*) is "obstructed" or "hampered".

| Rhetorical Device | Tactical Function | Example in the Kṣetra |
|---|---|---|
| **Jahat-svārthā** | Abandoning the literal | "The gallery is crying" (meaning the people in the gallery). |
| **Ajahat-svārthā** | Retaining the literal | "Protect the curd from crows" (implying all animals). |
| **Sāropā** | Imposition | "Food is God" |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | | (identifying the subject with the imposed). |
| **Sādhyavasānā** | Swallowing/ Intussusception | "This is a lion" (where the man is entirely "swallowed" by the lion-concept). |

The "loss of language" in this sphere is the loss of the ability to use and understand suggestion. When a people can only speak and think literally, they lose the "kingdom" of the imagination and the ability to navigate the complexities of social and political life. Suggestion (*Vyañjanā*) is the "covert operation" of the linguistic *Kṣetra*, enabling the maintenance of truth even under the "occupation" of literalism or censorship.

**Khatar Kaka and the Satirical Kṣetra: Deconstructing the Kingdom**

Prof. Harimohan Jha was not only a philosopher but also a renowned Maithili satirist, best known for his character "Khatar Kaka". Through Khatar Kaka, Jha applied the rigorous logic of the Nyāya tradition to the social and religious practices of his time, demonstrating that much of what was taken for "tradition" was actually a form of logical and linguistic "slavery".

In his work *Khatar Kaka Ke Tarang*, the protagonist uses logic to challenge the established "kingdom" of the feudal mind and social hierarchy. In one celebrated episode, Khatar Kaka mocks the "gullibility" of Arjuna in the *Mahabharata*, suggesting that Arjuna's hesitation on the battlefield of Kurukshetra was due to a lack of logical training. Krishna, in this view, wins the battle not just through divine power but through a superior linguistic and logical framework that "re-defines" the *Kṣetra* for Arjuna.

This satirical application reveals the "Language as Kṣetra" theme in its most vivid form. To Khatar Kaka, the "loss of language" is the inability to see through the "ritual arrangements" and "bhakti" that legitimate social inequality. By reclaiming the "Word" through logic and humor, the individual regains sovereignty over their own mind, effectively "overthrowing" the illegitimate kingdom of superstition and hierarchy.

**The Comparative Kṣetra: Jha vs. Western Analysis**

Jha's work is uniquely characterized by its engagement with Western analytic philosophy. He compares the Indian traditions of *Śabda-Bodha* with the conceptual analysis of thinkers like Russell, Moore, Wittgenstein, and Ayer. Jha argues that while the two traditions grew independently, they often cover common ground, albeit with different orientations.

A standout example is Jha's application of the Navya-Nyāya technique to Bertrand Russell's theory of descriptions. Russell's classic proposition, "Scott is the author of Waverley," is analyzed by Jha to show how the Indian concept of *Avacchedakatā* can offer a more nuanced specification of the identity and properties involved.

**Strategic Comparison of Analytic Frameworks**

Jha's comparison is a strategic attempt to defend the "kingdom" of Indian philosophy against the "encroachment" of Western thought by proving the superiority or at least equal sophisticatedness of the native tradition.

| **Theme of Analysis** | **Western Analytic View (Russell/Wittgenstein)** | **Indian Analytic View (Jha/Navya-Nyāya)** |
|---|---|---|
| **Meaning** | Use or logical atomism. | Śakti (potency) and Sphota (essence). |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **Propositio n** | Fact-representation. | Viśeṣya-Viśeṣaṇa relations hip. |
| **Incompati bility** | Logical contradiction. | Artha-Bādha or Ayogyatā . |
| **Synthetic Unity** | Synthetic Unity of Apperception (Kant). | Samasta-pratyaya-vimarśinī buddhi. |

The "loss of language" occurs when Indian scholars abandon their own categories—like *Sphota* or *Apoha*—because they lack exact synonyms in English. Jha warns that this linguistic "surrender" leads to a "loss of kingdom" where Indian thought is relegated to the status of a "folk religion" or mere "museum piece" rather than a living, sovereign philosophy. Reclaiming the language of Navya-Nyāya is, therefore, an act of intellectual decolonization and the restoration of a sovereign philosophical kingdom.

**The Determinants of Meaning: Border Controls of the Word**

To prevent the "loss of language," Jha emphasizes the fourteen determinant factors of meaning (*Saṃyoga*, *Viprayoga*, etc.) that act as the "border controls" of the linguistic *Kṣetra*. These factors ensure that a word is not "hijacked" by an incorrect meaning in a given context.

1. **Saṃyoga (Association):** Linking a word with a known companion (e.g., "The bow of Rama").
2. **Viprayoga (Dissociation):** Separating a word from a companion (e.g., "Rama without the bow").
3. **Sāhacarya (Companionship):** Mutual presence (e.g., "Rama and Lakshmana").
4. **Virodhitā (Opposition/Enmity):** Defining through contrast (e.g., "Rama and Ravana").
5. **Artha (Purpose):** The goal of the speaker.

6. **Prakaraṇa (Context):** The situational setting.
7. **Liṅga (Indicatory Mark):** Specific attributes.
8. **Anyasya sannidhiḥ (Vicinity of another word):** Meaning fixed by nearby terms.
9. **Sāmarthya (Capacity):** The inherent power of an entity.
10. **Auccitya (Propriety/Fitness):** Appropriateness to the situation.
11. **Deśa (Place):** Geographic or spatial context.
12. **Kāla (Time):** Chronological context.
13. **Vyakti (Gender/Individual):** Grammatical indicators.
14. **Svara (Accent):** Phonetic indicators.

These determinants are the "laws" of the linguistic kingdom. When they are followed, the "Word" remains sovereign and the meaning is secure. The "loss of language" is often a failure to apply these determinants, leading to the "border disputes" of ambiguity and confusion.

**The Process of Verbal Cognition: The Strategy of Śabda-Bodha**

The final victory in the *Kṣetra* of language is the attainment of *Śabda-Bodha*—valid verbal cognition. Jha analyzes the process through which a listener "takes possession" of the meaning intended by the speaker. This process is governed by four necessary conditions: *Ākāṅkṣā* (expectancy), *Asatti* (juxtaposition), *Yogyatā* (fitness/compatibility), and *Tātparya* (intention).

**The Conditions for a Valid Statement**

If these four "walls" are intact, the "kingdom" of the sentence is secure and the listener attains true knowledge.

| Condition | Function | Breach leading to "Loss of Language" |
|---|---|---|
| **Ākāṅkṣā** | The mutual need for words to complete a sense. | Fragmented speech that fails to communicate a whole idea. |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **Asatti** | The temporal or spatial proximity of words. | Delayed or disjointed speech that breaks the thread of thought. |
| **Yogyatā** | The logical compatibility of the concepts (e.g., not "watering with fire"). | Absurd or nonsensical speech that violates reality. |
| **Tātparya** | The overarching intention or purpose of the speaker. | Misinterpretation where the literal "words" are heard but the "spirit" is lost. |

Jha concludes that the synthesis of these factors leads to a *Vākyārtha-Bodha*—an understanding of the meaning of the sentence. This is the ultimate aim of all linguistic analysis. The "loss of kingdom" is the collapse of this process, where individuals no longer share a common *Śabda-Bodha*, leading to the total breakdown of social and intellectual order.

**Conclusion: Reclaiming the Sovereignty of the Word**

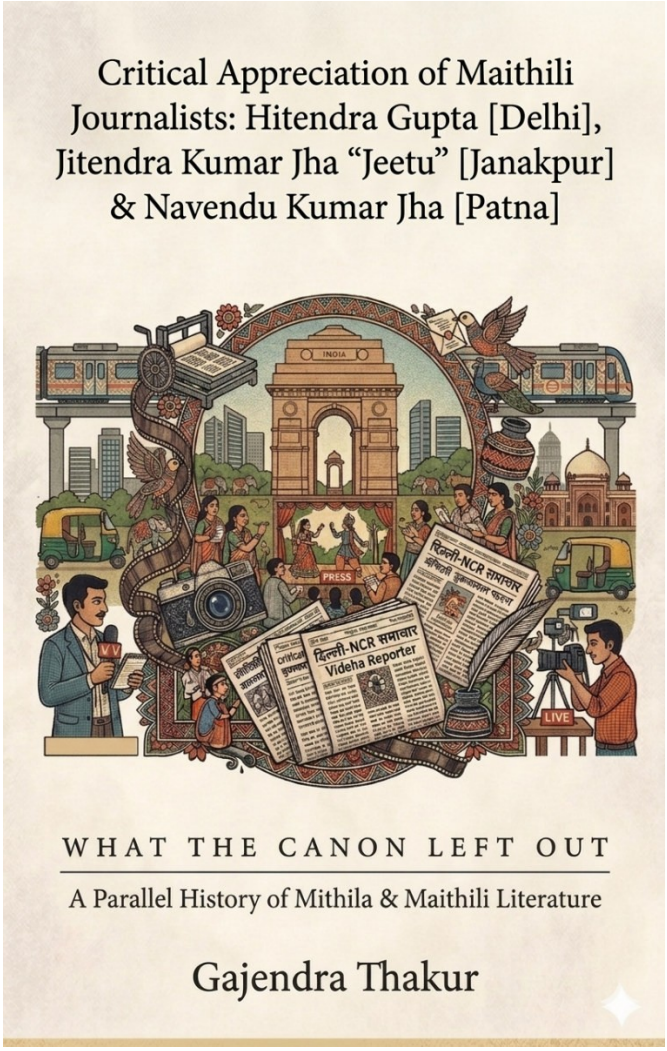
Prof. Harimohan Jha's linguistic framework is a call to intellectual arms. By viewing Language as *Kṣetra*, he warns that the battle for truth and sovereignty is fought first and foremost in the realm of the word. The "loss of language"—the forgetting of our logical delimiters, our rhetorical depths, and our metaphysical roots—is the certain precursor to the "loss of kingdom." To reclaim the kingdom, we must reclaim the precision of the Navya-Nyāya, the unity of the *Sphota*, and the wisdom of the *Vāk*. Jha's legacy, spread across his philosophical treatises and his Maithili satires, serves as a beacon for those who seek to defend the sovereignty of the word in an increasingly fragmented and ambiguous world.

Language as Kṣetra (Field of Battle)
Prof. Harimohan Jha's linguistic framework show that the loss of language is the loss of kingdom. Language as Kṣetra (Field of Battle)

Prof. Hari Mohan Jha’s work demonstrates that Indian philosophers treated language as a precise tool for analyzing reality. It is not nostalgia but a political diagnosis. When the Tirhuta script and pure vocabulary are lost, the avacchedaka (limiting criteria) for what constitutes 'Maithili' is erased. The postcolonial state, through Hindi/English hegemony, has imposed a vyadhikaraṇa abhāva (non-existence in a different locus)—the word 'Maithili' now exists, but its meaning has been relocated to a museum, not a living community. Amatya’s entire anthology is an attempt to restore sāmānādhikaraṇa (co-reference) between the signifier 'Maithili' and the signified 'dignity, land, and language'.

Thus, the loss of linguistic analysis is the loss of the kingdom because without the ability to analyze Sabda, one loses the ability to prove that the kingdom exists in the first place.

LESSON 025 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY




# I

## CRITICAL APPRECIATION

### HITENDRA GUPTA (DELHI)

*Maithili Journalist · Cultural Reporter · Correspondent*

*Indian & Western Literary-Journalistic Theory · Videha Parallel History Framework*

*Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa · Rasa-Dhvani-Vakrokti-Auchitya*

II

CRITICAL APPRECIATION

**JITENDRA KUMAR JHA 'JEETU' (JANAKPUR)**

*Maithili Theatre Journalist · Cultural Reporter · Nepal Correspondent*

*Indian & Western Literary-Journalistic Theory · Videha Parallel History Framework*

*Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa · Rasa-Dhvani-Vakrokti-Auchitya*

*III*

CRITICAL APPRECIATION

**NAVENDU KUMAR JHA (PATNA)**

*Senior Maithili Journalist · Radio Broadcaster · Cultural Chronicler*

*Indian & Western Literary-Journalistic Theory · Videha Parallel History Framework*

*Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa · Rasa-Dhvani-Vakrokti-Auchitya*

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*III*

# I. BIOGRAPHICAL AND CONTEXTUAL PROFILE

## A. Identity and Location

Hitendra Gupta (हितेन्द्र गुप्ता) is a Maithili journalist and cultural reporter based in Delhi — a member of the large Maithili diaspora community of the national capital that forms one of the most significant nodes in the network of Maithili cultural and political life outside Mithila proper. His journalistic work as documented in the Videha archive is conducted in Maithili, situating him within the tradition of Maithili-language journalism that the Videha eJournal has championed as a central component of the democratic parallel literary history.

Delhi has been a crucial centre of Maithili activism, journalism, and cultural production since at least the mid-20th century — home to Maithili organisations, literary events, and a continuous journalistic presence in the Hindi-language national press that has also maintained a distinct Maithili cultural identity. Hitendra Gupta's presence in the Videha archive as a journalist reporting on issues affecting the Mithila and Bihar region from a Delhi vantage point represents this tradition of the diaspora journalist who maintains connections to both the capital's political scene and the cultural concerns of the Mithila homeland.

## B. Videha Archive Presence

Hitendra Gupta appears in the Videha archive in the following confirmed entry:

'आब नहि खुलत नवका शराबक दोकान' (Āba Nahi Khulata Navakā Śarābaka Dokāna — No New Liquor Shops Will Now Open)

Published in: Videha Sadeha 23 (Prelim_23), pages 200–201. ISSN 2229-547X, www.videha.co.in.

This investigative/analytical journalism piece — on the Bihar government's decision to halt new liquor shop licences — is his primary documented contribution to the Videha archive. It appears in the same Sadeha volume as reports and essays by Navendu Kumar Jha (pages 186–189), Ganga Gunjan, Dr. Kailash Kumar Mishra, and Umesh Mandal's history of Maithili internet journalism — a volume that demonstrates the breadth of Videha's parallel journalistic history project.

## II. JOURNALISTIC CORPUS AND ANALYSIS

### A. 'Āba Nahi Khulata Navakā Śarābaka Dokāna' — Critical Analysis

This piece covers the Bihar government's policy decision to prohibit new liquor shop licences — a significant social policy story in the Bihar-Jharkhand political landscape with direct implications for the Maithili-speaking rural communities of Mithilanchal where alcohol-related social problems have been a longstanding concern. The title's direct declarative construction ('No new liquor shops will now open') is characteristic of hard news journalism: it leads with the decision and its finality.

From the perspective of Maithili journalism, this piece performs a crucial function within the Videha Parallel History Framework: it treats a Hindi-language political policy story as a matter of direct concern for the Maithili-speaking community and writes about it in Maithili. This is the journalistic equivalent of the Parallel History's literary assertion — that Maithili is a language of public affairs, policy discourse, and civic journalism, not merely of literature, song, and cultural expression.

The two-page length (pages 200–201) is typical of the analytical news-comment piece: long enough to provide context and implications, short enough to maintain journalistic pace. Within the broader Sadeha 23 context — which also contains Navendu Kumar Jha's report on the Vidyapati memorial event and Sushant Jha's historical analysis of Baliraj Garh — Gupta's piece represents the

current-affairs journalism strand of the Videha archive's diverse journalistic practice.

### B. Thematic Significance: Liquor Policy and Mithila

The liquor policy issue is not merely a bureaucratic story. In the Bihar-Mithila context, alcohol prohibition and liquor licensing have deep social dimensions: the relationship between alcohol consumption and domestic violence, agricultural debt, caste-based social hierarchies of drinking norms, and the wider question of state paternalism versus community self-determination. Bihar's eventual move to full alcohol prohibition under Chief Minister Nitish Kumar in 2016 was one of the most consequential Bihar policy decisions of the decade. Gupta's 2008 piece (Sadeha 23 dates from around 2008–2009) thus anticipates a major policy trajectory.

Writing about this issue in Maithili for the Videha platform is an act of linguistic democracy: it brings the policy discussion into the Maithili public sphere, treating Maithili speakers as citizens whose language is adequate to serious civic discourse. The Navya-Nyāya tradition's emphasis on śabda-pramāṇa (the authority of testimony) as a valid source of knowledge finds direct application here: journalistic testimony about policy decisions in Maithili constitutes valid civic knowledge for the Maithili-speaking community.

## III. THEORETICAL FRAMEWORKS

### A. Journalism as Śabda-Pramāṇa: Navya-Nyāya Analysis

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's analysis of śabda-pramāṇa (verbal testimony as valid knowledge) in the Tattvacintāmaṇi's fourth khaṇḍa is directly applicable to journalistic practice. For Gaṅgeśa, verbal testimony is valid when the vaktā (speaker/source) has genuine knowledge (tattvajñāna), communicates it accurately (tattvajñāna-vākya), and the listener has no countervailing evidence (abādhitaviṣayaka). The journalist's role, in Navya-Nyāya terms, is precisely to be a reliable vaktā — one whose testimony meets the conditions of śabda-pramāṇa.

Hitendra Gupta's reporting from Delhi on Bihar policy connects the national capital's decision-making apparatus (where the information originates) with the Maithili-speaking readership (who are the recipients of the knowledge). The anumāna (inferential) structure of investigative journalism — from observed

policy decision (hetu) through contextual analysis (vyāpti) to implications for the community (sādhya) — parallels the Navya-Nyāya structure of valid inferential cognition.

## B. Jürgen Habermas: Journalism and the Public Sphere

Jürgen Habermas's theory of the public sphere (Strukturwandel der Öffentlichkeit, 1962; translated as The Structural Transformation of the Public Sphere, 1989) provides the most directly relevant Western framework for evaluating Maithili journalism. Habermas argues that democratic public life requires a functioning public sphere — a domain of communicative action in which citizens discuss matters of common concern through reason-guided discourse rather than through power or tradition. A minority language's journalism is a constitutive element of its community's public sphere: without journalism in Maithili, Maithili speakers are excluded from the civic public sphere that Hindi and English journalism creates for their respective communities.

Hitendra Gupta's reporting — on a state policy directly affecting Bihar's Maithili-speaking population, written in Maithili for a Maithili-language journal — is a contribution to the Maithili public sphere in Habermas's precise sense. The Videha eJournal itself functions as a Habermasian public sphere institution: peer-reviewed, freely accessible, non-commercial, committed to reason-guided discourse on matters of concern to the Maithili community.

## C. Indian Alaṃkāra Tradition: Auchitya and Journalistic Propriety

Kshemendra's Auchityavicāracarcā (11th century) establishes auchitya (contextual propriety) as the supreme aesthetic principle. Applied to journalism, auchitya demands that each piece of reporting be appropriate to its subject, audience, and occasion. Gupta's piece on liquor policy demonstrates auchitya in its choice of subject (directly relevant to the Bihar/Mithila community reading Videha), its register (journalistic prose, not literary elaboration), and its placement in Sadeha 23 alongside other policy and cultural reportage.

## D. The Videha Parallel History Framework

The Videha Parallel History Framework's project of documenting the democratic, institutionally independent Maithili tradition includes not just

poetry, fiction, and literary criticism but journalism and civic discourse. Hitendra Gupta represents a specific category within this framework: the Maithili journalist based in the national capital, whose dual positioning gives him access to national policy information while maintaining the Maithili-language commitment that translates that information for the Maithili community.

The Framework's insistence that Maithili is a language of full civic life — not a museum language or a merely literary language — is embodied in Gupta's practice of bringing Delhi-based political journalism into the Maithili archive. His work confirms what the Parallel History asserts: that Maithili speakers are engaged citizens requiring coverage of the full range of civic affairs in their own language.

## IV. CRITICAL ASSESSMENT

Hitendra Gupta's documented Videha contribution is compact — a single two-page piece in Sadeha 23 — but its significance within the Parallel History Framework exceeds its length. It demonstrates that the Videha archive encompasses serious civic journalism alongside literary and cultural content; that the Maithili diaspora in Delhi produces journalism in Maithili for a Maithili readership; and that policy issues affecting Bihar and Mithila receive Maithili-language coverage within the Videha platform.

His position as a Delhi-based journalist writing in Maithili for the Videha platform places him within the tradition of what Gramsci would call the 'organic intellectual' of the migrant community: the journalist who maintains the community's cultural and linguistic identity while engaging with the political and civic life of the host city. This dual location — Delhi as institutional base, Mithila as cultural anchor — is structurally characteristic of the Maithili diaspora intellectual that the Videha Parallel History documents.

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II

CRITICAL APPRECIATION

**JITENDRA KUMAR JHA 'JEETU' (JANAKPUR)**

*Maithili Theatre Journalist · Cultural Reporter · Nepal Correspondent*

*Indian & Western Literary-Journalistic Theory · Videha Parallel History Framework*

*Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa · Rasa-Dhvani-Vakrokti-Auchitya*

# I. BIOGRAPHICAL AND CONTEXTUAL PROFILE

## A. Identity and Location

Jitendra Kumar Jha, known by his journalistic nickname 'Jīṭū' (जीतू), is a Maithili journalist and cultural reporter based in Janakpur, Nepal — the sacred city of Mithila, the ancient capital of King Janaka and the birthplace of Sītā (Jānakī), located in Madhesh Province, southern Nepal. His journalistic base in Janakpur places him at the geographical and cultural heart of Nepalese Mithila, the trans-border cultural zone that the Videha Parallel History Framework consistently treats as a single cultural unity spanning the India-Nepal boundary.

Janakpur is not merely a sacred city but the most prominent centre of Maithili cultural life in Nepal — home to the Mithila Cultural Corporation, the Mithila Heritage Museum, the annual Janaki Navami festival, and a dense network of Maithili cultural institutions. It is also the base of Nepal's Mithila political and civic activism. A journalist based in Janakpur has immediate access to both the cultural-religious events that define Maithili heritage and the political processes affecting Nepal's Madheshi/Maithili-speaking population.

## B. Pen-Name and Identity

The nickname 'Jīṭū' (जीतू) is an affectionate contracted form of 'Jitendra' — common in Mithila naming practice where bāul nāma (house-names/nicknames) are used alongside formal names. Its use in the Videha archive's byline ('riraport shri Jitendra Kumar Jha Jitu') signals that Jha is known within the Videha community under this intimate form, indicating a degree of personal familiarity and community embeddedness. The quotation marks around 'Jīṭū' signal its nickname status while retaining it as part of his journalistic identity.

## C. Videha Archive Presence

Jitendra Kumar Jha 'Jīṭū' appears in the Videha archive with the following confirmed entry:

'नचिकेताक "एक छल राजा"क मंचन' (Nacikettāka 'Eka Chala Rājā'ka Maṃcana — The Staging of Nachiketa's 'Once There Was a King')

Published in: Videha Sadeha 8 (Prelim_8), in the Theatre Reports section. ISSN 2229-547X, www.videha.co.in.

This is a theatre review/report on the staging of 'Eka Chala Rājā' (एक छल राजा — Once There Was a King), a play by the renowned Maithili playwright Udaya Narayan Singh 'Nachiketa'. The report is part of a substantial theatre-and-culture section in Sadeha 8 that includes reports on multiple Maithili dramatic productions and cultural events from both India and Nepal, including reports from Janakpur's Mithila Nāṭyakalā Pariṣad (MINAP) events, Mithiyātrika-Jhankāra, the Videha Maithili Nāṭya Utsava, and the International Maithili Theatre Festival.

## II. JOURNALISTIC CORPUS AND ANALYSIS

### A. 'Nacikettāka Eka Chala Rājā ka Maṃcana' — Critical Analysis

The report covers the staging of Udaya Narayan Singh Nachiketa's play 'Eka Chala Rājā' — a production by one of the most significant figures in contemporary Maithili drama. Nachiketa (born 1943), linguist and literary critic who headed Banaras Hindu University's linguistics department before returning to Nepal, is the author of multiple Maithili plays and the translator of a substantial body of Sanskrit and other theatrical works into Maithili. His plays occupy a central position in the Videha Parallel History's theatre section.

A theatre review report from Janakpur covering a Nachiketa production is a document of significant cultural-historical importance: it records a specific performance event, places it in the context of Maithili dramatic practice, and communicates it to the broader Videha readership across the India-Nepal geography. In a tradition where theatre performance is ephemeral — leaving no permanent record unless documented — the journalist's report is the primary archival trace.

The placement of Jha's report within Sadeha 8's comprehensive theatre section — alongside reports from Delhi (MINAP Delhi events), Berma (Nepal), and other locations — situates the Janakpur production within the pan-Maithili theatrical geography. This is the Parallel History Framework's characteristic

move: treating Maithili cultural production as a transnational unity, not divided by the India-Nepal border.

### B. The Nachiketa Connection and Cultural Significance

Udaya Narayan Singh 'Nachiketa' is one of the most significant figures in the Videha Parallel History. His 'Eka Chala Rājā' — whose title is a direct allusion to the traditional Maithili folk narrative opening formula ('Once there was a king...') — deploys the fairy-tale opening to critical, often satirical ends. Reporting on a production of this play from Janakpur, the cultural capital of Nepalese Mithila, is an act of cultural documentation with multiple layers of significance.

First, it documents the reception of a major Maithili play in its Nepalese cultural home. Second, it demonstrates that Janakpur's theatre culture engages seriously with contemporary Maithili dramatic literature from both sides of the border. Third, it places Jha as a culturally informed journalist — not merely a reporter of events but someone capable of contextualising the production within the larger Maithili theatrical tradition.

## III. POSITION WITHIN THE VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY

### A. Nepal-India Cultural Bridge

Jitendra Kumar Jha's journalistic position in Janakpur makes him a crucial figure for the Videha Parallel History Framework's insistence on the trans-border unity of Maithili culture. The political boundary between India and Nepal bisects Mithila geographically and administratively, but the Videha Framework — following the Vidyapati tradition that was itself both Indian and Nepalese — consistently treats the Maithili cultural community as a single entity. A journalist reporting from Janakpur for the Videha archive enacts this unity in institutional form.

The Sadeha 8 theatre section in which Jha's report appears is itself a demonstration of this trans-border cultural practice: it juxtaposes theatrical reports from Nepal (Janakpur's MINAP), India (various Bihar locations), and the diaspora (Delhi events) within a single cultural-journalistic framework.

Jha's contribution to this framework is the Janakpur viewpoint — the perspective from the cultural capital of Nepalese Mithila.

### B. Theatre Journalism and the Oral-Performative Tradition

Within the Videha Parallel History Framework, theatre journalism occupies a special position because theatre is the most immediate form of the oral-performative tradition that the Framework's folk culture strand privileges. Where the printed poem or novel can be archived directly, the performance event exists only in the moment — and the journalist's report is its primary trace in the historical record. Jha's theatre reporting thus performs a preservation function that is analogous to (though different from) Hriday Narayan Jha's folk song documentation: both create textual records of ephemeral cultural practices.

## IV. THEORETICAL FRAMEWORKS

### A. Navya-Nyāya: Pratyakṣa and the Theatre Review

Gaṅgeśa's analysis of pratyakṣa (direct perceptual knowledge) as the most reliable form of pramāṇa is directly relevant to the theatre reviewer's epistemological position. The theatre reviewer's knowledge of the performance is pratyakṣa — direct perception of what was enacted on stage — and this gives theatre journalism a special epistemological authority that other forms of cultural journalism lack. Jha's presence at the Janakpur staging of 'Eka Chala Rājā' as a reporter gives his account the status of savikalpa-pratyakṣa (determinate perceptual knowledge) — he perceived the production directly and organised that perception into a communicable report.

The chain from pratyakṣa to anumāna to śabda-pramāṇa is the structure of theatre journalism: the journalist perceives the performance (pratyakṣa), infers its quality and significance (anumāna), and communicates that judgment to readers who cannot attend the performance (śabda-pramāṇa). Jha's report thus functions as the śabda-pramāṇa that transmits knowledge of the Janakpur staging to the wider Videha readership.

## B. Walter Benjamin: The Reportage and the Staging

Walter Benjamin's analysis of the relationship between the original and its reproduction — and more specifically his essay 'The Author as Producer' (1934) — argues that progressive cultural journalism must not merely report on cultural events but situate them within the social conditions of their production. The question 'what is the quality of this staging?' must be supplemented by 'what are the conditions under which Maithili theatre is produced in Janakpur?' and 'what does the choice of a Nachiketa play for this audience say about the Janakpur theatre scene's cultural ambitions?'

Benjamin's concept of the Tendenz (political tendency) of art — the idea that form itself carries political meaning, not just content — is relevant to theatre journalism. A report that merely describes the plot and notes the audience's response is less adequate than one that attends to how the production's formal choices connect to the social reality of Nepalese Mithila. Jha's positioning as a Janakpur-based journalist gives him the contextual knowledge to make such connections.

## C. Habermas: Public Sphere and Theatre

Habermas's concept of the public sphere as the domain of rational-critical discourse on matters of common concern finds in theatre one of its historically primary institutions: from the Greek polis through the Elizabethan public theatre to the bourgeois literary public sphere, theatre has been a central space of public cultural debate. Maithili theatre in Janakpur is not merely entertainment but a form of public discourse about Maithili cultural identity, social values, and political aspirations — particularly in the context of Nepal's post-2006 federal restructuring and the Madheshi movement for autonomy.

Theatre journalism that documents and critically engages with this public cultural discourse is thus doubly a public sphere institution: it reports on a public sphere practice (theatre) for a public sphere platform (Videha). Jha's report from Janakpur is a contribution to the nested public spheres of Maithili cultural life in Nepal.

## D. Indian Rasa Theory Applied to Theatre Journalism

Bharatamuni's Nāṭyaśāstra, the foundational text of Indian theatrical theory, provides a framework for theatre journalism that is indigenous to the Maithili tradition. The reviewer's task in the rasa framework is not merely to describe the play but to assess whether the production successfully instantiates the

intended rasas — whether the vibhāva (determinants), anubhāva (consequents), and sañcārī bhāva (transient states) are effectively managed to generate the rasa-experience in the spectator. For a Maithili theatre reviewer, this framework is not an academic overlay but a living critical vocabulary rooted in the tradition's own self-understanding.

'Eka Chala Rājā's' satirical mode — the fairy-tale opening deployed for critical purposes — suggests that its primary rasas are Hāsya (comedy) and Raudra (controlled satirical fury), with elements of Vīra (heroic resolve) in the protagonist's challenges to authority. A Navya-Nyāya-informed theatre review would assess whether the production's anumāna (its chain of dramatic arguments) successfully establishes the vyāpti (general truth) that the play's specific narrative events are designed to demonstrate.

## V. CRITICAL ASSESSMENT

Jitendra Kumar Jha 'Jīṭū' occupies a specific and vital position within the Videha Parallel History's documentation of Maithili cultural life: as the journal's Janakpur correspondent for theatre, he provides the Nepal-based perspective that ensures the archive's pan-Maithili character. His report on the Nachiketa staging demonstrates the competence and cultural engagement of Janakpur's theatre journalism, and its preservation in the Sadeha 8 volume ensures that this ephemeral performance event has a permanent archival record within the Maithili digital heritage.

The brevity of his documented presence in the archive — a single confirmed report — reflects the limitations of the available archive rather than his significance. In a tradition where theatre documentation is sparse, even a single well-observed report has lasting value. The Videha Parallel History Framework's archival practice gives Jha's journalism the permanence it deserves.

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III

CRITICAL APPRECIATION

**NAVENDU KUMAR JHA (PATNA)**

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*Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa · Rasa-Dhvani-Vakrokti-Auchitya*

# I. BIOGRAPHICAL AND CONTEXTUAL PROFILE

## A. Identity, Formation and Location

Navendu Kumar Jha (नवेन्दु कुमार झा) is a senior Maithili journalist, radio broadcaster, and cultural chronicler based in Patna — the capital of Bihar and the principal institutional centre of Bihar's cultural, political, and journalistic life. His journalistic career spans print journalism, All India Radio (AIR) broadcasting, and digital journalism through the Videha platform. He is the most documented and prolific journalist in the three-figure group under consideration, with confirmed contributions across at least six Videha Sadeha volumes (Sadeha 10, 15, 23, 30, 34, and 35) covering a wide range of subjects: infrastructure development, caste sociology, social organisation, Maithili radio broadcasting, electoral politics, cultural festivals, and Bihari folk traditions.

Patna's significance as Navendu Kumar Jha's base cannot be overstated. As Bihar's capital, Patna is both the centre of the state's political and administrative apparatus and the principal hub of its media institutions — including All India Radio Patna, which has one of the longest and most significant histories of Maithili-language broadcasting in India. Jha's career at AIR Patna, combined with his print journalism career, makes him a figure who bridges the two principal media of Maithili public communication in the pre-internet era.

## B. All India Radio and Maithili Broadcasting

Navendu Kumar Jha's most historically significant documented contribution to the Videha archive is his essay 'Pacāsa Varṣaka Bhela Prādeśika Samācāra Ekāṃśa — 1993 me Prāraṃbha Bhela Chala Maithilīme Samācāraka Prasāraṇa' (पचास वर्षक भेल प्रादेशिक समाचार एकांश — 1993 मे प्रारंभ भेल छल मैथिली मे समाचारक प्रसारण — The Regional News Unit Has Completed Fifty Years: Maithili-Language News Broadcasting Began in 1993), published in Videha Sadeha 34 (Prelim_34), pages 380–388.

This piece is a primary historical document of Maithili radio journalism: it records the milestone of the AIR Patna Regional News Unit's fiftieth anniversary, including the specific historical fact that Maithili-language news broadcasting on AIR began in 1993. This date — 1993 — is a landmark in Maithili's institutional recognition as a media language, and Jha's

documentation of it is an act of archival preservation that the Videha Parallel History Framework regards as foundational.

The 1993 beginning of Maithili news broadcasting on AIR Patna predates Maithili's recognition as a Scheduled Language (which came in 2003 under the 8th Schedule amendment) by a decade — demonstrating that Maithili's institutional presence in broadcasting was established before its full constitutional recognition. Jha's journalism thus contributes to the record of Maithili's pre-recognition institutional history.

## C. Complete Documented Works in Videha Archive

Videha Sadeha 10 (Prelim_10): Three news reports — 'Rela Lāīnasāṃ Juṛata Bhārata Ā Nepāla' (India and Nepal will be connected by railway); 'Bhāratīya Sāmājika Vyavasthāme Āiyo Jīvanta Achi Jāti Vyavasthā — Prof. Sharma' (Caste system still living in Indian social order); 'Pradeśame Lāgata Cauadhahaṭā Nava Udyoga Samūha, ASSOCHAM Kaela Ehi Disa Pahala — Mithilāṃcalame Seho Lāgata Nava Udyoga' (Fourteen new industry groups in the province; ASSOCHAM initiative; new industries also in Mithilanchal).

Videha Sadeha 15 (Prelim_15): 'Ṭākāka Ābhāva Me Ṭhappa Achi Kosī Mahāsetūka Kāja Saharasā-Phārabisgaṃja Amāna Parivarttanaka Kāja Mada' (Work on Kosi Mahasetu stalled due to lack of funds; Saharsa-Forbesganj bridge work in limbo); reports on Maithili literary conference, MALASAM's sixth session, Chetana Samiti's 69th year.

Videha Sadeha 23 (Prelim_23): 'Astitvaka Lela Saṃgharṣa Karaita Paṭanāka Vidyāpati Smṛti Parva' (Struggling for existence: Patna's Vidyapati Memorial Festival), pages 186–189. A sustained cultural reportage piece on the festival's precarious institutional survival.

Videha Sadeha 30 (Prelim_30): Multiple pieces — 'Bihāraka Loka Parva-Chaṭhi' (Bihar's folk festival Chhath); 'Bihārame Sūryopāsanāka Pramukha Kendra' (Principal centres of sun-worship in Bihar); 'Vidyāpati Smṛti Divasa (11 November 2008) par Viśeṣa — Yaśasvī Kavi Chalāha Mahākavi Vidyāpati' (Special on Vidyapati Memorial Day: The illustrious poet Mahakavi Vidyapati); 'Upekṣita Achi Sonapura Ā Harihara Kṣetra Melā' (Sonepur and Harihar Kshetra Mela is neglected); 'Pradeśame Nahi Thami Rahal Jātīya Hiṃsāka Daura' (The cycle of caste violence in the state has not stopped); 'Rājagīrame Sampanna Bhela Saṃgha Ka Tīna Divāsīya Baisaka Gāme-Gāme Sakriya Hoyata Saṃgha' (Three-day RSS session in Rajgir; organisation will be active village to village); 'Gāma Me Vijñāna Keṃ Lokapriya Banaba Me

Lāgala Chhathi Mānasa Bihārī' (Manas Bihari engaged in popularising science in villages), pages 1387–1415.

Videha Sadeha 34 (Prelim_34): Key historical journalism piece — 'Pacāsa Varṣaka Bhela Prādeśika Samācāra Ekāṃśa' (Regional News Unit's 50 years; 1993 Maithili news broadcasting began); 'Satāka Prāpti Banala Bhājapāka Uddeśya' (Attaining power has become BJP's aim), pages 380–388.

Videha Sadeha 35 (Prelim_35): Multiple reports — India-Nepal railway connectivity; caste system; industrial development in Mithilanchal; Bihar elections (three phases, voter enthusiasm, political parties' anxiety, Rahul Gandhi's Bihar mission); 'Dū Varṣa Pūrā Kaela Maithilī Dainika Mithilā Samāda' (Two years completed by Maithili daily Mithila Samad), pages 405–416.

# II. THEMATIC ANALYSIS OF THE JOURNALISTIC CORPUS

## A. Infrastructure and Regional Development

Navendu Kumar Jha's infrastructure journalism — on the India-Nepal rail link, the Kosi Mahasetu (Great Koshi Bridge) project, the ASSOCHAM initiative for Mithilanchal's industrial development — addresses one of the most urgent practical concerns of the Mithila region. The Koshi river's annual floods, the lack of adequate bridge and rail infrastructure connecting the Terai to the mainland, and the economic underdevelopment of Mithilanchal relative to western Bihar are longstanding features of the region's marginalisation within the Bihar and national development framework.

His report on the Koshi Mahasetu ('Ṭākāka Ābhāva Me Ṭhappa Achi Kosī Mahāsetūka Kāja') — the great bridge across the Koshi river linking Saharsa and Forbesganj — is a piece of advocacy journalism: it documents governmental failure to fund a project critical to the region's connectivity and economic development. Writing this in Maithili for the Videha platform ensures that the Maithili-speaking community receives this information in their own language — a basic democratic requirement.

## B. Cultural Journalism: Vidyapati, Chhath and Mithila Heritage

Jha's cultural journalism on the Vidyapati Memorial Festival, the Chhath folk festival, the Sonepur Mela, and Harihar Kshetra demonstrates sustained engagement with the living cultural traditions of Mithila and Bihar. His piece 'Astitvaka Lela Saṃgharṣa Karaita Paṭanāka Vidyāpati Smṛti Parva' — 'Struggling for existence: Patna's Vidyapati Memorial Festival' — is particularly significant: it documents the precarious institutional situation of the Vidyapati festival, the major annual celebration of Maithili's greatest poet, in the Bihar capital.

The Vidyapati Memorial Festival's 'struggle for existence' in Patna is itself a Parallel History story: the canonical figure who should receive the most generous institutional support is instead fighting for survival in an institutional environment that privileges Hindi-language cultural events over Maithili ones. Jha's documentation of this struggle is an act of cultural advocacy — recording the neglect as well as the celebration.

His special report on Mahakavi Vidyapati for the 11 November 2008 Vidyapati Memorial Day ('Vidyāpati Smṛti Divasa par Viśeṣa — Yaśasvī Kavi Chalāha Mahākavi Vidyāpati') places the celebration of Vidyapati within the contemporary cultural context — not as a museum-piece commemorated annually but as the living ancestor of the present Maithili literary tradition.

## C. Radio Broadcasting History: The 1993 Landmark

The most historically consequential piece in Jha's documented Videha corpus is the article on AIR Patna Regional News Unit's 50 years, with its central finding that Maithili-language news broadcasting began in 1993. This is primary source material for the history of Maithili media — a landmark date that deserves placement in the chronology of Maithili's institutional development.

The period 1993–2003 is a crucial decade in Maithili's institutional history: from the beginning of AIR news in Maithili (1993) through the Maithili internet presence (Videha founder Gajendra Thakur's early web activity) to the formal Scheduled Language recognition (2003). Jha's documentation of the 1993 start date contributes to a fuller understanding of this decade, showing that institutional recognition in broadcasting preceded formal constitutional recognition by ten years.

### D. Political Journalism: Elections and the Communal Question

Jha's political journalism — on Bihar elections (voter enthusiasm, Rahul Gandhi's Bihar mission, BJP's power-seeking agenda) — demonstrates that the Videha parallel journalism tradition does not confine itself to cultural topics but engages fully with the political processes that directly affect the Maithili-speaking electorate. His observation 'Matadātā Sabhaka Utasāha Madhya Sampanna Bhela Tīna Caraṇaka Matadāna — Rājanaitika Dalaka Becainī Baṛhauane Achi Matadātāka Cuppī' (Three-phase voting completed amid voter enthusiasm; voters' silence has increased political parties' anxiety) is a perceptive analysis of the gap between democratic participation and political representation — a gap that has particular resonance for Mithila's historically marginalised political situation.

## III. THEORETICAL FRAMEWORKS

### A. Navya-Nyāya: Anumāna and Investigative Journalism

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's analysis of anumāna (inference) in the Tattvacintāmaṇi's second khaṇḍa provides a formal structure for understanding investigative journalism's epistemic logic. The journalist's task in a piece like 'Koshi Mahasetu work stalled' is precisely anumāna: from the hetu (observed fact — the work has stopped), through the vyāpti (general principle — government projects stall when funds are withheld), to the sādhya (conclusion — the government has failed to allocate the required funds). The journalist's work is the identification and verification of the vyāpti, the general principle that gives the specific observation its significance.

The Navya-Nyāya tradition's emphasis on the precision of technical vocabulary — its development of highly specific logical terms (viśeṣaṇa, pratiyogitā, anuyogitā) to capture subtle distinctions — is structurally analogous to good journalism's requirement for precision in attribution, evidence, and inference. Both practices are fundamentally concerned with the valid derivation of knowledge from evidence.

### B. Gaṅgeśa's Geography: Mithila as Epistemic Home

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya was a Maithil, born and writing in Mithila. Navendu Kumar Jha is a Patna-based Maithili journalist writing for the Videha archive —

an institution whose editorial practice traces its intellectual genealogy through the Mithila tradition to Gaṅgeśa. The epistemological framework that Gaṅgeśa developed in Mithila is the framework within which Maithili journalism operates: the concern for valid knowledge (pramā), reliable testimony (śabda), and valid inference (anumāna) that Gaṅgeśa systematised is the intellectual heritage within which Jha's journalistic practice is situated.

This geographical-intellectual connection between Gaṅgeśa's Mithila and Jha's journalism is not merely metaphorical. Gaṅgeśa's concern with the conditions under which language transmits valid knowledge is directly relevant to the journalist's concern with accurate, evidence-based reporting. The Navya-Nyāya tradition's suspicion of invalid inference (hetvābhāsa — fallacious reasoning) maps onto journalism's suspicion of bias, sensationalism, and unverified claims.

## C. Jürgen Habermas: Public Sphere and Maithili Broadcasting

Habermas's theory of the public sphere (1989) distinguishes between the 'political public sphere' (where citizens discuss matters of state) and the 'literary public sphere' (where cultural matters are publicly debated). Navendu Kumar Jha's corpus spans both: his reporting on elections, the BJP's agenda, and Bihar development is political public sphere journalism; his cultural reporting on Vidyapati, Chhath, and Maithili radio is literary-cultural public sphere journalism. Both are necessary for a functioning Maithili democratic public sphere.

The 1993 beginning of Maithili news broadcasting on AIR is significant precisely in Habermasian terms: broadcasting creates a public sphere at scale, reaching listeners who cannot read newspapers or access digital platforms. The beginning of Maithili AIR news in 1993 marks the extension of the Maithili public sphere into the broadcast medium — a critical democratic development. Jha's documentation of this milestone is itself a contribution to the public sphere's self-awareness.

## D. The Videha Parallel History Framework

Navendu Kumar Jha is the most comprehensive journalist in the Videha Parallel History's documentation of Maithili journalism. His breadth — from infrastructure to cultural heritage to radio history to electoral politics — maps the full range of what civic Maithili journalism aspires to cover. His Patna base gives him access to both the Bihar government and the cultural institutions of

the state capital, making him a bridge between the political and the cultural dimensions of Maithili public life.

Particular note should be taken of two aspects of his contribution to the Parallel History. First, his documentation of the Mithila Samad Maithili daily newspaper ('Dū Varṣa Pūrā Kaela Maithilī Dainika Mithilā Samāda') — recording the two-year milestone of the first Maithili daily newspaper — is a landmark in Maithili media history. Second, his sustained reporting on the Vidyapati Memorial Festival's institutional precarity documents the contradiction at the heart of Bihar's cultural policy: the greatest Maithili poet is officially celebrated but inadequately supported.

## IV. CRITICAL ASSESSMENT

Navendu Kumar Jha is among the most significant figures in the Videha Parallel History's journalistic strand. His corpus across six Sadeha volumes is the most extensive of any journalist in the archive, covering more than a decade of Maithili journalism from Patna. His range — from the Koshi bridge to the AIR news history to the Vidyapati Festival to Bihar elections — demonstrates the full scope of what Maithili civic journalism can and should address.

Three contributions stand out as historically significant. The 1993 AIR Maithili news broadcasting date (Sadeha 34) is primary historical data for Maithili media history. The report on Mithila Samad's two-year anniversary (Sadeha 35) documents the founding of the first Maithili daily newspaper. And the series of Vidyapati Festival reports (Sadeha 23, 30) provides a multi-year documentation of the festival's institutional precarity that is available nowhere else in the Maithili public record. These three contributions alone justify placing Navendu Kumar Jha in the first rank of the Videha Parallel History's journalistic contributors.

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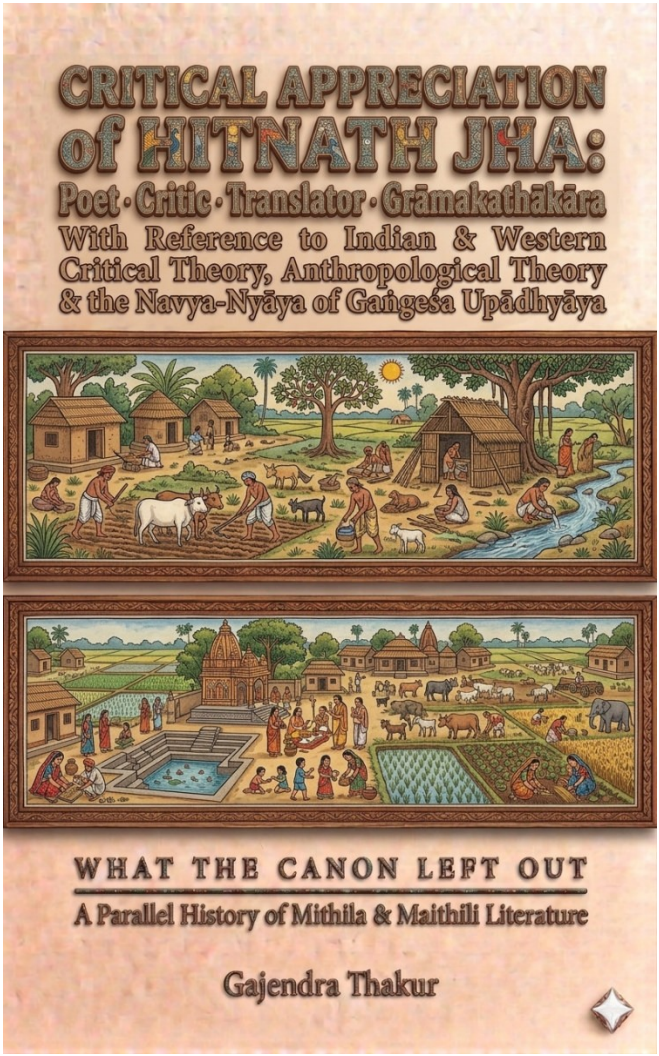


# CRITICAL APPRECIATION

*of*

**HITNATH JHA**

*Poet · Critic · Translator · Grāmakathākāra*

With Reference to Indian & Western Critical Theory,

Anthropological Theory & the Navya-Nyāya of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya

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## I. Preface: Method and Materials

This critical appreciation of Hitnath Jhā (हितनाथ झा) is grounded in the primary texts made available through the Videha digital platform (www.videha.co.in), India's first and longest-running Maithili fortnightly e-journal (since 2000, ISSN 2229-547X), edited by Gajendra Thakur. The primary sources consulted include: (1) Koilakh (ग्रामगाथा, 2017), a village-biography and gram-itihas; (2) Lekh-Rekh (लेख-रेख, Pothi Prasaṅg, Pāṭhakīya, 2023), a collection of critical and reader-responses covering nearly sixty works of Maithili literature; (3) Kavitā: Śambhu Bādalaka (कविता: शम्भु बादलक, 2023), Maithili translations of the Hindi progressive poet Shambhu Badal; (4) Triveni (त्रिवेणी, 2020), a collection of appreciations of writers honoured by the Trivenikaant Thakur Sahitya Samman; (5) Maithilī Itihāsk Rekhānkan (मैथिली इतिहासक रेखांकन, 2003), a historical survey co-edited with Dr. Chandreshwar Kavi; and (6) the Videha Issue 405 (November 2024), a landmark 28-article special issue devoted entirely to Hitnath Jhā.

The critical methodology applied here is deliberately interdisciplinary, bringing together four frameworks in a structured dialogue: (a) the classical Indian poetic tradition of Rasa-Dhvani-Aucitya, as systematised by Bharata, Ānandavardhana and Kṣemarāja; (b) the Navya-Nyāya epistemological method pioneered in Mithila by Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (fl. c. 1325 CE) in his Tattvacintāmaṇi; (c) western literary theory from Aristotle through the Russian Formalists, New Critics, postcolonial theory and ecocriticism; and (d) cultural anthropology and ethnographic theory, particularly as developed by Clifford Geertz, Bronisław Malinowski, and the tradition of thick description.

The choice of Navya-Nyāya as an analytical lens is not merely decorative. Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya was himself a Maithil philosopher, born at Chadana in the Mithila region and living at Karion, twelve miles south-east of Darbhanga — the very geographical heartland from which Hitnath Jhā's ancestral village Koilakh draws its deepest cultural identity. To apply the Navya-Nyāya's pramāṇa-centred epistemology (based on pratyakṣa — perception; anumāna — inference; upamāna — comparison; and śabda — testimony) to the literary corpus of Hitnath Jhā is therefore not an anachronistic imposition but a homecoming of ideas across centuries.

# II. Biographical Introduction and Cultural Context

## A. Vital Facts

The following biographical data is drawn primarily from the परिचय section of Videha Issue 405 (November 2024):

| | |
|---|---|
| **Full Name** | Hitnath Jhā (हितनाथ झा) |
| **Date of Birth** | 6 June 1956 |
| **Native Village** | Koilakh, Pubar Tol, Madhubani District, Mithila (Bihar) |
| **Residence** | Hazaribagh, Jharkhand |
| **Father** | Late Taranath Jhā (b. 1933) — editor of the handwritten Maithili journal Prabhāt (1933) |
| **Mother** | Bhāgīrathī Devī |
| **Brothers** | Prof. Bhīmnāth Jhā; Late Mitranāth Jhā |
| **Education** | B.Sc. (Science Graduate) |
| **Profession** | Retired Senior Branch Manager, Bank (government banking sector) |
| **Wife** | Śrīmatī Nīrū Jhā |
| **Children** | Dhanañjaya Jhā (son); Rītu Jhā (daughter) |
| **Gotra** | Kaśyapa (Khauvāḍe Nāhis line — vide Bhīmnāth Jhā's vaṃśāvalī) |
| **Email** | hitanathjha@gmail.com |
| **Honour** | Pañ. Babuā Jhā Memorial Trust, Koilakh |

## B. Family and Cultural Lineage

Hitnath Jhā belongs to a family with a deep tradition of Maithili intellectual engagement. His father Taranath Jhā (1933) was the editor of Prabhāt, a handwritten Maithili periodical — a remarkable act of cultural custodianship in an era when Maithili print culture was still nascent. His elder brother, Prof. Bhīmnāth Jhā, is a well-known Maithili scholar. The vaṃśāvalī (genealogical poem) composed for the Videha special issue by Bhīmnāth Jhā traces the family lineage through twenty-nine generations back to the ancient scholar Vācaspati (the name resonates with Vācaspati Miśra, the celebrated 9th-century Mithila philosopher), underscoring the deep rootedness of the family in the Maithil brahmin intellectual-literary tradition.

This lineage is not merely ornamental. As Ashish Anchinhār observes in his biographical essay in Videha 405, to understand Hitnath Jhā's literary sensibility one must understand the dual inheritance: the village of Koilakh (which has produced multiple scholars, doctors and administrators) and the diasporic existence in Hazaribagh (Jharkhand). The creative tension between the rooted village-self and the displaced professional-self is the generative engine of his literary project.

## C. Literary Emergence: Retirement as Second Birth

Hitnath Jhā's literary career flourished almost entirely after his retirement from the banking sector. This is a pattern noted and celebrated in multiple articles in Videha Issue 405. Pravīṇ Kumār Jhā writes in his essay "Soaśal Mīḍiyāk Sadupayogasam Riṭāyarmeṇṭak Bād Banal Sāhityakār Hitnath Jhā" that rather than retreating into the passivity of old age, Hitnath Jhā deployed social media — particularly Facebook — as a vehicle for literary engagement, criticism, and community building. He began posting reviews and appreciations of Maithili books on Facebook, which attracted the attention of scholars including the retired IAS officer Dhīrendra Mohan Jhā, who encouraged him to deepen his critical output.

Kalpanā Jhā in her essay for the same special issue places Hitnath Jhā in a pointed contrast to a common post-retirement literary temptation: "Retirement ke bād kichhu log Maithilī mẽ kathā-kavitā likha lāgait chhai je ki mātr puraskār o maṃcak lel hoet chai. Ekr viprit Hitnath Jhā riṭāyarmeṇṭak bād apan lekhan lel grām itihas evam pāṭhakīya likhab chunalāh je ki ekṭā anirvāy kāj chai sāhitya lel." (Translation: "After retirement, some people begin writing stories and poems in Maithili only for awards and stages. In contrast, Hitnath Jhā chose after retirement to write gram-itihas and reader-responses, which are

an indispensable service to literature.") This observation encapsulates the distinctive ethic of Hitnath Jhā's literary practice: service over self-promotion.

## III. The Literary Corpus: A Survey

Hitnath Jhā's published output, though relatively compact, represents an extraordinary range of literary forms and functions. The corpus as documented in the Videha परिचय section (2024) is as follows:

### *1. Maithilī Itihāsk Rekhānkan (*मैथिली इतिहासक रेखांकन*, 2003)*

Co-edited with Dr. Chandreshwar Kavi, this historical survey of Maithili literature is the earliest major publication and establishes Jhā's scholarly credentials. It situates Maithili literary history within its broader cultural and sociological matrix, anticipating the anthropological approach that would define his later Koilakh.

### *2. Koilakh (*कोइलख*, ग्रामगाथा / ग्रामेतिहास, 2017)*

Koilakh is arguably Hitnath Jhā's most significant and discussed work. It is a gram-gāthā (village-narrative) and gram-itihās (village-history) of his ancestral village Koilakh in Madhubani district. The work documents the geography, demography, cultural heritage and intellectual heritage of Koilakh, a village that has produced remarkable scholars across centuries — including the great Maithili Akademi scholars Pt. (Prof.) Khuddi Jhā and Pt. Babuājī Miśra (the first and second professors of Maithili at Calcutta University), Śrīkānta Ṭhākur Vidyālaṅkāra (first president of Maithili Akademi, Patna), Pt. (Mahākavi) Kāśīkānta Miśra 'Madhup', and the social reformer Vāṇī Candrāvatī.

Reviewed extensively in the Videha special issue, Koilakh draws comment from nine scholars. Siyarām Jhā "Saras" calls it a "vilakṣaṇ abhilekh" (remarkable record) of gram-gāthā. Dr. Kailāsh Kumār Miśra's essay "Sārsvat Paricāyikā: Koilakh" documents the work's demographic and sociological data (the village population c. 8,500 in 2011 Census), while also noting that the book's silence on non-brahmin castes is a limitation that future scholarship must address — a critique voiced also by Prof. Maheśvarlāl Dās.

### *3. Triveni (*त्रिवेणी*, 2020)*

Triveni is a 128-page collection of appreciations of literary figures honoured by the Trivenikaant Thakur Sahitya Samman, Hazaribagh. It represents Jhā's work as a literary facilitator and curator of recognition, bringing together assessments of contemporaries in a format that blends biographical essay with critical appreciation. The title "Triveni" — the confluence of three sacred rivers — is symbolically apt for a work that brings together biography, criticism, and commemoration.

### *4. Lekh-Rekh (*लेख-रेख*, Pothī Prasaṅg Pāṭhakīya, 2023)*

This is perhaps Hitnath Jhā's most formally innovative work. Lekh-Rekh presents pāṭhakīya (reader-responses) and brief critical reviews of works across Maithili literature. According to its Preface (by Dr. Laliteś Miśra), this is very likely the first Maithili book to present in a single volume the detailed review and description of one entire author's corpus — covering 9 novels, 8 story collections, 19 poetry books, 2 essay collections, 5 memoirs, 6 critical books, 1 play, and 1 autobiography, in addition to reviews of 70+ individual titles from the broader Maithili literary field. Multiple reviewers in Videha 405 (Udaya Candra Jhā Vinoda, Kumār Vikramāditya, Kalpanā Jhā) note that the pāṭhakīya form as practised in Lekh-Rekh occupies a space between casual reading-note and formal samīkṣā (review), performing a distinctive critical function in a literary ecosystem that is chronically under-reviewed.

### *5. Kavitā: Śambhu Bādalaka (*कविता*:* शम्भु बादलक*, 2023)*

This is a Maithili translation of 29 Hindi poems by the progressive Hindi poet Prof. Shambhu Badal (Professor Emeritus, Hindi Department, Vinoba Bhave University, Hazaribagh — a National Sahitya Akademi member, 2008–2013, whose poems had previously been translated into Bengali, Telugu, Gujarati and English). The selection took Hitnath Jhā approximately fifteen years to complete, and reflects his sustained engagement with the craft of literary translation. The work contains prefaces by Kīrtināth Jhā and Kedar Kanan.

### *6. Rājāpotā Balagara (*राजापोता बलगर*,* बाल कविता संग्रह*, 2024)*

A collection of 46 children's poems, this work reveals an altogether different creative register — that of the bāl-sāhityakāra (children's literature writer). Ābhā Jhā and Ujjval Kumār Jhā, reviewing it in Videha 405, note that Jhā brings to children's poetry the same ethnographic attentiveness to

landscape, folk memory and village life that characterises Koilakh, producing verse that is simultaneously local and universal.

## IV. Hitnath Jhā as Poet: Translation and Original Verse

### A. The Translation of Shambhu Badal: Poetics and Ethics

The translation of Shambhu Badal's poems into Maithili (Kavitā: Śambhu Bādalaka, 2023) is the most concentrated demonstration of Hitnath Jhā's poetic sensibility. Shambhu Badal belongs to the tradition of progressive Hindi poetry that draws its energy from adivasi life, exploitation, and resistance — themes centred in the Jharkhand-Bihar borderland that Hitnath Jhā has himself inhabited during his professional life in Hazaribagh.

In his translator's preface ("Anuvād Prasaṅg: Dū Ākhar"), Jhā articulates a clear translation ethics: the translator's primary obligation is to preserve the mūl bhāvanā (original emotional core) of the poem while finding, in the target language, words that carry the same weight of lived experience. He writes that he began translating Koilhā Mocī (a poem about a cobbler) at a public reading event in Hazaribagh in 2019, where Badal's poem was read aloud, and found that translating it into Maithili came to him as a felt necessity rather than a scholarly exercise.

Dr. Ābhā Jhā, in her essay "Bhāṣāntarak Utkṛṣṭ Prayās — Kavitā Śambhu Bādalak" (Videha 405), applies the Sanskrit concept of anuvāda-dharma (the ethics of translation) to evaluate the work. She argues that Hitnath Jhā successfully navigates the central paradox of literary translation — fidelity to the source versus readability in the target — by choosing Maithili lexical equivalents that are rooted in common usage rather than Sanskritised registers, thereby preserving Badal's class-conscious voice. Kīrtināth Jhā's prefatory essay "Śambhu Bādalak Kavitā: Jīṅgīk Rośanī" praises the translations as illuminating the original rather than merely reproducing it.

## B. The Poems of Shambhu Badal: Social Vision and Aesthetic Form

The 29 poems selected for translation by Hitnath Jhā represent the core of Shambhu Badal's political and humanist vision. Kedar Kanan, in his essay "Kavitā Śambhu Bādalak: Nav Svar, Nav Sandhān" (Videha 405), identifies the central impulse of Badal's verse as the desire to break yathāsthiti (the status quo) — to speak for the śoṣit (exploited) majority against the forces of economic exploitation, state betrayal and communal false consciousness. This vision, notes Kanan, is expressed through a deceptively simple poetic language, one whose accessibility is a political choice rather than a literary limitation.

Kumār Manīś Arvind's long essay "Kavitā Śambhu Bādalak: Hazāribāg Parisarak Viśiṣṭ Sugandhi se Mahamahāit Kavitā Sabhakẽ Paṛhait" (Videha 405) provides the richest reading of the translated poems, noting how Badal's vision of Hazaribagh — its forests, its adivasi communities, its coal mines and their aftermath — finds in Maithili a second home. Arvind argues that Hitnath Jhā's selection privileges poems in which landscape functions not merely as backdrop but as protagonist: Hazaribag, Mā, Shikar (Hunting), Gujarā (Passing), Gāy (Cow), Prachanakār evam Janatā (Writer and People).

Applying the rasa theory of Bharata's Nāṭyaśāstra to Badal's poems (as translated by Jhā), one observes a dominant karuṇa-rasa (pathos) shot through with sustained vīra-rasa (heroic determination) — the combination that defines committed social poetry across traditions. The poems do not fall into sentimentality because their language is stripped of ornament: this corresponds to the aucitya (propriety) principle of Kṣemarāja, wherein the fitness of language to content is itself the aesthetic achievement.

## C. Rājāpotā Balagara: The Children's Poet

The 46 children's poems in Rājāpotā Balagara represent a significant lateral movement in Hitnath Jhā's output. Ābhā Jhā's review in Videha 405 notes that these poems draw on the same village ecology as Koilakh — birds, ponds, seasons, the rhythms of agricultural life — but refracted through a child's perceptual frame. This use of the child-persona to recover a sense of wonder at the natural world connects to a broader tradition in Maithili children's literature going back to Vidyāpati's lighter compositions, while also engaging with the pan-Indian tradition of bāl-kavitā.

# V. Hitnath Jhā as Critic and Reviewer: Lekh-Rekh

## A. The Form of Pāṭhakīya

Lekh-Rekh is the most formally significant of Hitnath Jhā's contributions to Maithili literary culture. The pāṭhakīya — a "reader's note" or reader-response — occupies an intermediate critical space that Indian literary theory does not systematically address but which has a long informal existence in Sanskrit commentary culture (the vṛtti, the ṭīkā, the āhvāna). Āśīṣ Ancinhār's essay in Videha 405, "Pāṭhakīya Vidhā evaṃ Hitnath Jhā," provides the most careful theoretical account of this genre.

Ancinhār draws a careful distinction between pāṭhakīya, samīkṣā (review), ālocanā (criticism) and samālocanā (critical analysis), arguing that the pāṭhakīya is the most intellectually honest of these forms precisely because it foregrounds the reader's subjectivity rather than claiming the false objectivity of the formal reviewer. In Lekh-Rekh, this subjectivity is disciplined: Jhā's responses are informed by wide reading, comparative awareness and a principled literary ethics, but they never pretend to the authority of the professional ālocanā.

## B. Structure and Scope of Lekh-Rekh

The book covers the following categories of Maithili literary production: novels by Nandipati Dās (Bangaṭ Bābūk Aṅgrejī), Kedarnath Chaudhary (Ayinā), Namonaath (Dosar Ahalyā), Subhāṣcandra Yādav (Maḍar), Kumār Manīś Arvind (Micchhāmī Dukkaaṃ), Pankaj Parāśar (Jalaprantar), Bhaveścandra Miśra 'Śivāṃśu' (Sonicaṛaiyā), Dhīrendra Kumār Jhā (Uttarārdha), and Dilīp Kumār Jhā (Sirāur). Additionally, the book covers short story collections, poetry volumes, and critical works, as detailed in the book's index. The range is striking: it covers both established senior writers (Nandipati Dās, Kedarnath Chaudhary) and younger voices (Kumār Manīś Arvind, Pankaj Parāśar), demonstrating a democratic critical sensibility.

Udaya Candra Jhā Vinoda, in his Videha 405 essay "Lekh-Rekh: Anuśīlanaka ek Vilakṣaṇ Bānagī," calls Lekh-Rekh a "specimen of critical cultivation" (anuśīlanaka bānagī), arguing that the work's greatest achievement is its consistent maintenance of analytical distance: Hitnath Jhā never allows personal friendship or institutional affiliation to distort his assessments. This independence of judgment is itself a form of critical virtue rarely seen in small

literary communities where most critics are also friends, rivals and colleagues of those they review.

### C. Critical Principles in Lekh-Rekh

Reading across the pāṭhakīyas in Lekh-Rekh, one can reconstruct Hitnath Jhā's implicit critical principles: (1) Accessibility — does the work communicate with a wide reading public without condescending to it? (2) Yathārtha (realism) — does the work engage honestly with the social, material and emotional realities of Maithili life? (3) Bhāṣā-śuddhi (linguistic propriety) — does the author deploy Maithili with craft and care, avoiding both unnecessary Sanskritisation and careless colloquialism? (4) Navaprāyogitā (formal innovation) — does the work extend the possibilities of its genre rather than simply reproducing convention?

These principles, while never explicitly stated by Jhā, are consistent with the aucitya theory of Kṣemarāja, which holds that the fitness of each element — language, form, content, emotional register — to its context is the ultimate measure of literary value. They are also consistent with the engaged criticism of the progressive Indian critical tradition represented by figures like Ramacandra Shukla in Hindi and Taranand Viyogi in Maithili (whose Karmadharaya is the most comparable recent work of Maithili literary criticism).

## VI. Hitnath Jhā as Grāmakathākāra: Koilakh and the Village-Biography

### A. The Gram-Gāthā as Literary Form

Koilakh represents Hitnath Jhā's most ambitious literary achievement and his most original formal contribution. The gram-gāthā (village-narrative) or gram-itihās (village-history) is not a new form — Sanskrit literature has its sthala-māhātmya (sacred geography) tradition, and modern Indian literature has produced village-centred chronicles — but Jhā's Koilakh is distinctive in combining rigorous historical documentation with the literary warmth of a memoir and the analytical precision of sociological writing.

The work covers: the geographical setting and historical origins of Koilakh; its notable alumni across the centuries (from Umāpati Upādhyāya of

the 16th century to modern doctors, scholars and administrators); its social structure and caste composition; its educational history; and its embedded relationship with the intellectual culture of Mithila. As Siyarām Jhā "Saras" writes in Videha 405: in a single volume, the reader gains access to Koilakh's history, geography, current demographic data (c. 8,500 in 2011 Census), the intellectual genealogy of the Pārijāt Hariṇ of Umāpati Upādhyāya, the first two professors of Maithili at Calcutta University, the Śāstravartā Mārttaṇḍa Puṭṭī Jhā, and a procession of exceptional Maithil intellectuals across half a millennium.

## B. Critical Assessments of Koilakh

Nine scholars contribute reviews of Koilakh in Videha 405, making it the most reviewed work in the special issue. The assessments identify both the work's extraordinary strengths and its acknowledged limitations. Among the strengths: the meticulous archival research (the book draws on oral history, documentary sources and family genealogies); the graceful prose style that makes historical information accessible; and the evident affective investment of the author, whose love for his village animates every page without distorting the historical record.

Among the limitations identified: Prof. Maheśvarlāl Dās notes that the book contains no mention of non-brahmin jātis (castes) of Koilakh, asking whether this is a deliberate choice or an inadvertent blind spot — and arguing that a truly comprehensive village biography must represent all the village's people. Dr. Kailāś Kumār Miśra notes with concern that the village's literacy rate as of 2018 stands below 60%, a fact that sits uncomfortably alongside the celebration of the village's intellectual traditions. These critiques are important and represent precisely the kind of honest, engaged commentary that Hitnath Jhā himself practises in Lekh-Rekh.

## C. Āśīṣ Ancinhār's Theoretical Supplement

Āśīṣ Ancinhār's essay "Sthānavibhanā, Nagaravibhanā, Grāmavibhanā (Mithilāk sandarbhame)" in Videha 405 provides a theoretical supplement to Koilakh, arguing that the deficiency of formal literary categories — "sthāna-description," "nagara-description," "grāma-description" — in Maithili criticism has led to an under-theorisation of the gram-gāthā form. His essay proposes a framework for evaluating such works on three axes: demographic inclusivity, historical depth, and affective authenticity. By these criteria, Koilakh scores very high on the latter two and requires expansion on the first.

## VII. Hitnath Jhā as Translator: Theory and Practice

Translation is the site where Hitnath Jhā's multiple roles — poet, critic, cultural worker — converge most productively. His Maithili translation of Shambhu Badal's Hindi poems constitutes a significant act of cultural bridging, connecting two neighbouring literary traditions that share geographical and social realities but are separated by language and critical infrastructure.

The theoretical stakes of literary translation have been debated in Indian aesthetics from at least the time of the poetic manuals (kāvyaśāstra) that discussed the concept of anuvāda (repetition/translation) in relation to the original (mūla). Eugene Nida's distinction between "formal equivalence" and "dynamic equivalence" in translation theory (Toward a Science of Translating, 1964) provides a useful Western comparative frame. In Jhā's translations of Badal, one observes a commitment to dynamic equivalence: the priority is to produce in the Maithili reader the same experiential response that the Hindi original produces in the Hindi reader, rather than to reproduce formal features at the expense of effect.

Dr. Ābhā Jhā's analytical reading of specific translated poems demonstrates concretely how this principle operates. In Badal's poem "Koilhā Mocī" (Cobbler), the Hindi language's directness of social statement is preserved in Maithili through the choice of everyday Maithili vocabulary rather than literary Maithili — a choice that keeps the poem anchored in the lived world of labour and community. In the poem "Hazāribāg," the specificity of the Jharkhand landscape — its forests, hills, and the sounds of its rivers — translates into Maithili without loss because Maithili has its own rich vocabulary of the natural world rooted in the Mithila ecosystem, which shares ecological registers with the Chota Nagpur plateau.

# VIII. Critical Frameworks I — Indian Poetics: Rasa, Dhvani, Aucitya

## A. The Rasa Theory (Bharata, Abhinavagupta)

The rasasūtra of Bharata's Nāṭyaśāstra — vibhāva + anubhāva + vyabhicāribhāva → rasa — provides the foundational category for evaluating the affective achievement of literary work in the Indian critical tradition. Applied to Hitnath Jhā's corpus, one observes a dominant emotional palette centred on śānta-rasa (serenity, equanimity) as the foundational register, with karuṇa-rasa (pathos) activated in the social poems and translations, vīra-rasa (heroic resolve) in the critical writing, and adbbhuta-rasa (wonder) in the nature-centred passages of Koilakh and the children's poems.

What is particularly notable is the absence of the raudra-rasa (fury) and vībhatsa-rasa (disgust) that characterise more aggressively political writing. Hitnath Jhā's critical and creative work maintains a fundamental equanimity even when addressing social injustice, caste exclusion and literary neglect. This śānta-rasa foundation corresponds, in his personal literary ethics, to the principle identified by Laxman Jhā "Sagar" in Videha 405: Hitnath Jhā practises a form of literary sattva (purity of motive) that resists the corruption of commercial ambition and factional literary politics.

## B. Dhvani Theory (Ānandavardhana)

Ānandavardhana's Dhvanyāloka (9th century CE) establishes dhvani — resonance or suggestion — as the "soul of poetry" (kāvyasya ātmā dhvaniḥ). The theory holds that the greatest poetry operates on three simultaneous levels: vācya (literal meaning), lakṣyārtha (implied meaning) and vyañjanā (suggested or resonant meaning). Applying this framework to Hitnath Jhā's translations of Shambhu Badal, one finds that the best of the translated poems successfully preserve the dhvani of the originals — a test that is far more demanding than simple semantic accuracy.

In Badal's poem "Mā" (Mother), the literal subject is the poet's mother, but the dhvani extends outward to encompass the mother-tongue (Jharkhand's adivasi languages, Hindi, Maithili in Jhā's translation), the motherland (the Chota Nagpur landscape), and the primordial nurturing force that capitalism and development discourse perpetually threaten. Hitnath Jhā's Maithili translation preserves all three levels of meaning, making visible in the process

the deep structural resonances between Maithili and Bhojpuri-Hindi literary cultures.

### C. Aucitya (Kṣemarāja) and Sāhitya-Darpaṇa (Viśvanātha)

Kṣemarāja's theory of aucitya (propriety, or the fitness of each element to its context) provides a precise tool for evaluating the critical writing in Lekh-Rekh. Hitnath Jhā's pāṭhakīyas are characterised by exactly this propriety: the vocabulary, length, tone and analytical depth of each response is calibrated to the nature of the work under consideration. A slender volume of children's poetry receives a different — shorter, lighter, more impressionistic — response than a densely argued novel.

Viśvanātha Kavirāja's Sāhitya-Darpaṇa (14th century) defines sāhitya (literature) as the unity of śabda (word) and artha (meaning) infused with rasa. This holistic definition proves useful in evaluating Koilakh, which operates simultaneously as a śabda-text (a carefully composed prose narrative) and as an artha-text (a historically documented account of real persons and places). The fusion of these two dimensions — the aesthetic and the archival — is what gives Koilakh its distinctive authority.

## IX. Critical Frameworks II — The Navya-Nyāya of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya

### A. Gaṅgeśa: The Mithila Connection

The application of Navya-Nyāya epistemology to literary criticism requires first a recognition of the profound historical connection between the Navya-Nyāya school and the Mithila region. Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (fl. c. 1325 CE) — the founder of the school — was born in Chadana village in Mithila and lived and worked at Karion (twelve miles south-east of Darbhanga). His sole surviving work, the Tattvacintāmaṇi ("The Thought-Jewel of Truth"), also known as Pramāṇacintāmaṇi, initiated what Satis Chandra Vidyābhūṣaṇa identifies as the "Modern Period" of Indian logic. Hitnath Jhā's ancestral village Koilakh is itself situated in the Madhubani district of the same Mithila region, and the intellectual culture that Koilakh documents is inseparable from the Navya-Nyāya tradition that shaped Mithila's scholarly self-image for six centuries.

Gaṅgeśa's Tattvacintāmaṇi systematises knowledge around four pramāṇas (valid means of knowledge): pratyakṣa (perception), anumāna (inference), upamāna (comparison/analogy) and śabda (verbal testimony). The Navya-Nyāya school developed, beyond Gaṅgeśa, a sophisticated technical language for precision analysis, involving concepts such as viśeṣya (the qualified), viśeṣaṇa (the qualifier), sambandha (relation), avacchedaka (limitor) and pakṣatā (inferential focus). This apparatus, while designed for logical and epistemological analysis, offers unexpected resources for literary criticism — particularly for the evaluation of what critics know, how they know it, and how their knowing is structured.

## B. Pratyakṣa (Direct Perception) in Literary Reading

In Navya-Nyāya, pratyakṣa (direct perception) is the foundational pramāṇa — the immediate, unmediated encounter with the object. Applied to literary criticism, pratyakṣa corresponds to the direct reading experience: what the text does to a reader in the act of reading, prior to interpretation. Hitnath Jhā's pāṭhakīyas in Lekh-Rekh are remarkable for their fidelity to pratyakṣa — to the actual experience of reading the text, before theoretical frameworks are applied. His responses begin with "I read this and it felt like..." rather than "According to theory X, this text is..." This phenomenological honesty is rare in institutionalised literary criticism and corresponds precisely to the Navya-Nyāya insistence on anchoring all knowledge in perception before moving to inference.

## C. Anumāna (Inference) in Critical Reasoning

Anumāna — inference from evidence — is the second pramāṇa and the one that receives the most elaborate treatment in Gaṅgeśa's Tattvacintāmaṇi. The classic Nyāya inferential schema: Pakṣa (subject of inference), Sādhya (what is to be proved), Hetu (the reason/evidence), Vyāpti (invariable concomitance), and Dṛṣṭānta (example). Applying this schema to Hitnath Jhā's critical judgments:

*Pakṣa: The pāṭhakīya in Lekh-Rekh maintains critical independence from institutional literary politics.*

*Sādhya: This independence reflects a principled literary ethics.*

*Hetu: The reviews cover both celebrated and marginalised authors, praising and critiquing each on grounds internal to the work.*

*Vyāpti: Works that assess literary quality on grounds internal to the text rather than on the basis of author's reputation are invariably independent.*

*Dṛṣṭānta: The review of a debut novelist is given the same analytical care as the review of an established senior writer.*

This schema makes visible the logical structure of Hitnath Jhā's critical practice in a way that mere impressionistic description cannot. The Navya-Nyāya insistence on explicit articulation of the hetu (reason) and vyāpti (invariable concomitance) demands that the critic show their logical workings — a demand that Hitnath Jhā's most rigorous pāṭhakīyas do in fact meet, even when the vocabulary is discursive rather than formal.

## D. Upamāna (Analogical Comparison) in Literary Evaluation

Upamāna — knowledge derived from comparison and analogy — is the third pramāṇa and corresponds in literary criticism to comparative method: understanding a text by comparing it to others of similar type, different type, or in different traditions. Hitnath Jhā deploys upamāna most explicitly in Lekh-Rekh, where individual works are consistently evaluated in relation to the broader corpus of Maithili literature and (implicitly) to pan-Indian standards of the form.

In the preface to Lekh-Rekh, Dr. Laliteś Miśra makes explicit use of upamāna in locating the book's significance: it is compared to other forms of Maithili critical writing (the editorial preface, the foreword, the scholarly review-article) and found to occupy a sui generis position. This comparative locating is precisely the function of upamāna as Gaṅgeśa describes it: knowledge of a new object through its resemblance to and difference from known objects.

## E. Śabda (Verbal Testimony) and the Authority of the Literary Record

Śabda — knowledge derived from reliable verbal testimony (āptavacana) — is the fourth pramāṇa and corresponds in literary criticism to the authority of the textual record, the scholarly tradition, and the testimony of earlier critics. Hitnath Jhā's Maithilī Itihāsk Rekhānkan (2003) is the most sustained exercise in śabda-pramāṇa: it assembles, evaluates and synthesises the verbal testimony of the Maithili literary tradition from its earliest period to the modern.

The Navya-Nyāya school, following Gaṅgeśa, insists that the reliability of śabda depends on the trustworthiness of the source (āptatva) and the clarity of

its expression (abhihitatva). In Maithilī Itihāsk Rekhānkan, Hitnath Jhā and his co-editor Dr. Chandreshwar Kavi apply implicit criteria of āptatva in selecting which literary-historical sources to cite and synthesise, demonstrating a śabda-critical faculty that is the practical equivalent of the Navya-Nyāya epistemologist's evaluation of testimony.

### F. Pakṣatā and Vyāpti in Critical Writing

Two further Navya-Nyāya concepts prove particularly generative for literary criticism. Pakṣatā refers to the "inferential focus" — the specific locus of doubt or inquiry that motivates an inference. In literary criticism, pakṣatā corresponds to the critical question that organises a piece of writing: "Is this poem successful?" "Does this novel achieve its stated goals?" "Is this translation faithful to its original?" The discipline of identifying a clear pakṣatā before proceeding to critical analysis is something that the best of Hitnath Jhā's pāṭhakīyas exemplify and that the weakest analytical writing (in any language) lacks.

Vyāpti — the invariable concomitance between the hetu (reason) and the sādhya (conclusion) — demands that critical generalizations be supported by consistent evidence. When a critic says "Maithili fiction of the twenty-first century is characterised by psychological depth," the vyāpti requires that this claim hold across all or most relevant instances. Hitnath Jhā's characteristically modest, provisional formulations in Lekh-Rekh — "In this work it seems to me that..." — are a safeguard against premature vyāpti-claims: they acknowledge the reader's particular experience rather than claiming universal application.

## X. Critical Frameworks III — Western Literary Theory

### A. Formalism and the Structure of Meaning

The Russian Formalist distinction between "device" (priyom) and "material" (material) — developed by Viktor Shklovsky, Roman Jakobson and others in the 1910s and 1920s — provides a useful analytical lens for Hitnath Jhā's translation practice. Shklovsky's concept of ostranenie (defamiliarisation) — making the familiar strange through artistic technique — applies directly to the translation of Badal's poems: the act of reading a Hindi poem in Maithili

produces exactly this defamiliarisation effect, forcing the Maithili reader to encounter the social realities of Jharkhand's adivasi and working-class communities with fresh eyes, as if for the first time.

The New Critical insistence on close reading — on the primacy of the text as a verbal object — is consonant with the pratyakṣa emphasis of Navya-Nyāya and with the best of Hitnath Jhā's critical practice. I. A. Richards' distinction between "sense," "feeling," "tone" and "intention" as the four dimensions of any utterance (Principles of Literary Criticism, 1924) provides a framework that maps productively onto Hitnath Jhā's pāṭhakīyas, which regularly attend to all four dimensions even without naming them explicitly.

## B. Postcolonial and Subaltern Theory

Hitnath Jhā's gram-itihās Koilakh is illuminated by postcolonial and subaltern theory, particularly the Subaltern Studies project's insistence on recovering histories from below — histories of communities and regions that colonial and nationalist historiography had marginalised or erased. Ranajit Guha's argument (in Elementary Aspects of Peasant Insurgency in Colonial India, 1983) that the peasant and the village community are historical subjects with their own epistemic frameworks resonates strongly with the project of Koilakh, which documents a village culture that produces remarkable scholars and citizens while remaining invisible to mainstream Indian literary and historical discourse.

Homi K. Bhabha's concept of the "third space" — the hybrid cultural space produced by colonial and postcolonial encounter — is relevant to Hitnath Jhā's own cultural position as a Maithil from Hazaribagh, perpetually negotiating between the Maithili homeland culture of Mithila and the Jharkhand diaspora context. This cultural in-between-ness, rather than producing rootlessness, generates a dual vision that enriches both his gram-itihās writing (where Mithila is seen through the lens of distance) and his translation work (where the Jharkhand of Shambhu Badal is seen through the lens of cultural kinship).

## C. Reader-Response Theory

Hitnath Jhā's practice of pāṭhakīya is most directly illuminated by the reader-response tradition in Western literary theory: Hans Robert Jauss's aesthetics of reception (Rezeptionsästhetik) and Wolfgang Iser's theory of the implied reader (Der Implizite Leser, 1972). Jauss argues that a literary work's meaning is not fixed in the text but is produced in the interaction between the

text and its historically situated reader. Iser argues that the reader is always also a co-author, filling the "gaps" and "indeterminacies" of the text with their own experience and imagination.

Hitnath Jhā's pāṭhakīyas are explicit enactments of this reader-response dynamic. They do not claim to deliver the meaning of the text but to record one reader's encounter with it — an encounter shaped by the reader's biography, cultural position, reading history and aesthetic sensibility. This is not relativism (all readings are equally valid) but perspectivism (every reading is situated, and the best readings acknowledge their situatedness). Āśīṣ Ancinhār's theoretical account of the pāṭhakīya in Videha 405 arrives at essentially the same position from within the Maithili critical tradition.

## D. Ecocriticism and the Literature of Place

Both Koilakh and the Shambhu Badal translations invite ecocritical analysis — the study of the relationship between literature and the natural environment (as theorised by Lawrence Buell in The Environmental Imagination, 1995, and The Future of Environmental Criticism, 2005). Koilakh is as much a biography of a landscape as of a community: the ponds, groves, fields and water-bodies of the village are documented with the same affective care as its human inhabitants. The poem cycle of Badal translated by Jhā is similarly grounded in the specific ecology of the Chota Nagpur plateau — its sal forests, its rivers, its monsoon rhythms.

Buell's criteria for "ecocentric" literature — that the nonhuman environment is present not merely as a frame but as a presence; that human interest is not the only interest; that human accountability to the environment is part of the text's ethical orientation — are met in both Koilakh and the Badal translations. This ecocentric orientation connects the literature of Hazaribagh-Jharkhand to the broader pan-Indian environmental literature tradition documented by Ramachandra Guha and others.

# XI. Critical Frameworks IV — Anthropological and Ethnographic Theory

## A. Thick Description: Geertz and Koilakh

Clifford Geertz's concept of "thick description" — the interpretive method that reads cultural behavior as a text, attending to layers of meaning rather than bare behavioral facts (The Interpretation of Cultures, 1973) — is the most directly applicable anthropological framework for Koilakh. Geertz argues that the anthropologist's task is not to describe behavior (thin description: "he winked") but to interpret the layered cultural meanings that make a behavior intelligible within a specific community (thick description: "he performed a parody-wink as part of a rehearsed burlesque, knowing his audience would recognize it as such").

Koilakh practices thick description of village life: the annual cycle of festivals is not merely listed but embedded in the agricultural calendar, the kinship structure and the mythological cosmology that gives each festival its meaning. The biographies of notable Koilakh alumni are not mere curriculum vitae but thick narratives that locate each life in the social, economic and intellectual currents of its time. This thickness of description is what distinguishes Koilakh from a mere topographical or genealogical directory, and it is what makes the work a significant contribution to the anthropology of the Maithil brahmin community.

## B. Malinowski and Participant Observation

Bronisław Malinowski's method of participant observation — the anthropologist's sustained immersion in the community being studied — is relevant to understanding Hitnath Jhā's relationship to his subject matter. Jhā is not an outside observer of Koilakh: he is a native son of the village, deeply embedded in its kinship networks, its oral traditions and its living memory. Yet his professional life in Hazaribagh provides exactly the productive distance that allows him to see what those who never left cannot see: the village's distinctiveness, its historical significance, and its vulnerabilities.

This combination of insider knowledge and outside perspective is the ethnographer's ideal condition, described by James Clifford in The Predicament of Culture (1988) as the productive tension between "dwelling" and "traveling." Hitnath Jhā dwells in the memory of Koilakh while traveling (literally and culturally) in the professional and intellectual spaces of Hazaribagh and the

Maithili literary diaspora. Koilakh is the literary crystallisation of this productive tension.

## C. Victor Turner and the Social Drama

Victor Turner's concept of the "social drama" — the sequence of breach, crisis, redressive action and reintegration that characterises conflicts within communities (The Ritual Process, 1969) — provides a structural lens for reading the narratives embedded in Koilakh. The histories of Koilakh's notable figures are, in many cases, social dramas: the scholar who left the village to seek education in Calcutta, the administrator who returned to serve the region, the reformer who challenged caste orthodoxy. These are not merely biographical data but structural narratives about the relationship between the individual and the community, the local and the national.

## D. Benedict Anderson and Imagined Communities

Benedict Anderson's theory of the "imagined community" (Imagined Communities, 1983) — the argument that nations and cultural communities are produced through shared practices of reading, narration and commemoration rather than being natural or primordial entities — illuminates both Koilakh and the broader cultural project of Maithili literature in which Hitnath Jhā participates. The Maithili literary community is precisely such an imagined community: it exists through the shared practice of writing, reading and critiquing in Maithili, sustained by journals like Videha and by critics like Hitnath Jhā who keep the tradition's memory alive and growing.

Koilakh itself is an act of community-imagining: it gathers into a single textual space the dispersed memories and achievements of a village community, making them available to future generations who may never have lived in the village but who can now participate in its imagined identity. The Videha special issue on Hitnath Jhā is similarly an act of community-imagining: 28 scholars contributing from different parts of India and the diaspora, assembling a collective portrait of one writer as a way of affirming the community's shared values and histories.

# XII. Hitnath Jhā in the Maithili Literary Tradition

## A. The Long Literary Heritage

Maithili literature traces its origins to the 10th century CE, with the earliest significant prose work — Jyotirishwar Thakur's Varṇaratnākara — appearing in the early 14th century. The towering figure of Vidyāpati (c. 1352–1448), known as the "Maithil Kavi Kokil" (the Cuckoo Poet of Maithili), dominates the medieval period. In the colonial and modern period, figures such as Chanda Jhā (who revolutionised Maithili by freeing it from exclusively devotional and amatory registers), Harimohan Jhā, Yatri (Nagarjun), Kanchinath Jhā "Kiran," Rājkamal Chaudhary, Surendra Jhā "Suman," and Chandranath Miśra "Amar" have defined the tradition's direction.

Hitnath Jhā enters this tradition at a moment of paradox: Maithili has more writers and publications than at any previous point in its history, yet its critical infrastructure — the apparatus of reviews, scholarly monographs and institutional recognition — remains chronically underdeveloped. The Sahitya Akademi recognised Maithili in 1965, the 8th Schedule of the Constitution included it in 2004, and the state of Jharkhand recognised it in 2017; yet Bihar, the homeland of Maithili, has not yet granted it official language status. In this context, the work of critics and reviewers like Hitnath Jhā is not supplementary but foundational: without critical reflection, a literature cannot develop self-awareness.

## B. Hitnath Jhā and the Tradition of the Grāmakathākāra

Within the Maithili tradition, the closest predecessor to Hitnath Jhā's Koilakh is the grāma-māhātmya tradition of Sanskrit literature, which documented the sacred geography and cultural heritage of specific places. In modern Maithili literature, Jagadīś Prasād Maṇḍal's Gamak Jīṅgī and related works of village-centred fiction have explored similar territory, but in the mode of imaginative literature rather than historical documentation. Hitnath Jhā's achievement in Koilakh is to create a new hybrid form: the grāma-itihās-gāthā, which is simultaneously documentary history, cultural anthropology and literary memoir.

### C. The Reviewer as Cultural Worker

In the Maithili context, Hitnath Jhā's work as a reviewer and pāṭhakīya-writer fills a structural vacuum. Taranand Viyogi's Karmadharaya (the most substantial piece of Maithili literary criticism in recent decades) operates at a more theoretical and comprehensive level than Lekh-Rekh, but its scope is necessarily limited by the demands of scholarly argument. Hitnath Jhā's pāṭhakīyas operate at the level of the informed general reader, performing the crucial cultural function of keeping new books in view, creating a sense that literary production is being noticed and responded to, and thereby sustaining the motivation of writers who might otherwise feel they are writing into a void.

Dr. Kailāś Kumār Miśra's essay in Videha 405, "Hitnath Jhā Samarpita Pāṭhak ker Sākāṅkṣa Pratinidhi," characterises Hitnath Jhā as "the representative of the dedicated reader" — a term that captures something essential about his cultural function. He is not the professional critic who pronounces from a position of institutional authority, but the exemplary reader who shows by example what committed, careful, generous reading looks like.

## XIII. Social Media, Retirement, and the Late-Flowering Writer

One of the most striking aspects of Hitnath Jhā's literary career is its timing: the great bulk of his published work appeared after his retirement from the banking sector, and his initial literary emergence came through Facebook rather than through traditional print channels. Pravīṇ Kumār Jhā's essay in Videha 405 documents this trajectory in detail, arguing that Hitnath Jhā's career represents a model for how retired professionals can use social media platforms as a bridge between their professional expertise and literary vocation.

The Facebook-to-publication pipeline that characterises Jhā's output is worth examining carefully. His practice of posting brief reader-responses and book notices on Facebook served multiple functions: it tested ideas in a responsive public forum; it built a readership that already existed before the books appeared; and it created a network of literary interlocutors (the retired IAS officer Dhīrendra Mohan Jhā, the publisher Kedar Kanan, the critic Āśīṣ Ancinhār) who encouraged and supported his literary development.

Comparing this trajectory to comparable examples in other Indian literary contexts, one is reminded of Walter Benjamin's argument (in "The Storyteller," 1936) that the death of the storyteller in industrial modernity is mourned precisely because the storyteller was always the person whose life-experience was rich enough to be worth sharing — and that this richness typically came with age. Hitnath Jhā's late literary flourishing is a vindication of Benjamin's implicit argument: the retired bank manager who has spent decades reading Maithili literature, observing village life and professional culture, and navigating the complexities of a diasporic identity, has a wealth of experience that only needs the right formal vehicle to become literature.

Hitnath Jhā's advice to young writers, quoted in Pravīṇ Kumār Jhā's essay, is characteristically grounded: "Apanā sabhakẽ sadai apan parivārak ādhārī rahbāk cāhī" (One should always remain anchored to one's family). This insistence on familial rootedness as the foundation of literary life connects to the anthropological insight that cultural production is always embedded in social networks — that the writer does not spring fully formed from individual genius but from communities of care, memory and obligation.

## XIV. Limitations and Areas for Further Research

Any critical appreciation, to be useful rather than merely celebratory, must identify its own limitations and the gaps in its subject's corpus. Several such limitations present themselves in the case of Hitnath Jhā:

First, the caste and class constitution of Koilakh as documented in the book represents primarily the brahmin intellectual tradition of the village, as multiple reviewers note. A comprehensive anthropological account of Koilakh would require documentation of all its communities — Yadav, Teli, Dhobi, Musahar and other communities whose presence in the village is presumed but undocumented. Hitnath Jhā himself does not claim comprehensiveness in this regard, but future extensions of the gram-itihās project must address this gap.

Second, the Maithilī Itihāsk Rekhānkan (2003) and Triveni (2020) : The critical appreciation's engagement with these works is based on secondary sources and brief textual references only.

Third, Hitnath Jhā's own original poetry — as distinct from his translations of Shambhu Badal — receives relatively limited treatment in this appreciation, partly because the original poetic output available is limited to what appears in the Videha special issue. A more comprehensive assessment of his poetic voice would require access to his Facebook posts and any journal publications.

Fourth, the application of Navya-Nyāya categories to literary criticism developed in this essay is exploratory and suggestive rather than technically rigorous in the manner of a specialist in Indian logic. A collaboration between a Navya-Nyāya specialist and a Maithili literary scholar would be needed to develop this analytical method to its full potential.

## XV. Conclusion

Hitnath Jhā's literary career represents an important and distinctive contribution to contemporary Maithili literature. His significance can be summarised under four headings, corresponding to his four primary roles:

As a grāmakathākāra, Koilakh establishes him as the founder of a new hybrid literary form — the gram-itihās-gāthā — that combines historical documentation, cultural anthropology and literary memoir in a synthesis that has no precise precedent in Maithili writing. The work's dense evocation of Koilakh's intellectual heritage, its honest acknowledgment of the village's continuing challenges (low literacy, incomplete social inclusion), and its affective richness make it a model for how literature can serve the work of community memory.

As a pāṭhakīya-writer and reviewer, Lekh-Rekh fills a structural gap in Maithili's critical infrastructure. By demonstrating what committed, independent, generous reading looks like, Jhā performs a cultural service that is simultaneously humble (he claims only to be a reader, not a scholar) and consequential (he keeps new writing in view and creates the conditions for literary accountability).

As a translator, his Kavitā: Śambhu Bādalaka brings the progressive social poetry of Jharkhand into Maithili, creating a literary bridge between two communities whose lives are geographically adjacent but culturally separated. The translations are successful precisely because they prioritise dynamic equivalence over formal fidelity — they aim to move the Maithili reader as the

originals move the Hindi reader, rather than to reproduce the surface features of the source text.

As a literary historian and critical-biographical essayist, his work in Maithilī Itihāsk Rekhānkan and Triveni extends the project of Maithili self-documentation that is essential to the survival and development of a literary tradition that has historically been under-documented and under-valued in the institutional structures of Indian literary culture.

Applied across these four roles, the critical frameworks deployed in this appreciation — the Indian rasa-dhvani-aucitya tradition, the Navya-Nyāya pramāṇa-analysis of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya, Western literary theory from Formalism through postcolonial and ecocritical approaches, and the cultural anthropology of Geertz, Malinowski and Turner — converge on a common judgment: that Hitnath Jhā's literary work is characterised by intellectual honesty, formal conscientiousness, cultural service and a deep rootedness in the landscape, language and community of Mithila. These are not small virtues. In a literary culture that often rewards the spectacular over the substantial, the institutional over the independent, and the ornate over the honest, Hitnath Jhā's example is quietly exemplary.

The Videha special issue on his work (Issue 405, November 2024), with its 28 essays by scholars spanning multiple generations and disciplines, constitutes a collective act of recognition that is itself a landmark in Maithili critical culture. To be the subject of such rigorous, diverse and honest attention — including criticism as well as celebration — is the highest form of literary recognition that a community can offer one of its own.

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[Contains essays by: Gajendra Thakur; Praṇav Kumār Jhā; Kalpanā Jhā; Jagadīś Candra Thakur "Anil"; Āśīṣ Ancinhār; Vinayānand Jhā; Dr. Dhanākar Thakur; Dr. Kailāś Kumār Miśra; Pandit Bhavanāth Jhā; Siyarām Jhā "Saras"; Prof. Maheśvarlāl Dās; Śrīmatī Nīlam Jhā; Udaya Candra Jhā Vinoda; Kumār Vikramāditya; Kalpanā Jhā; Dr. Ābhā Jhā; Dr. Kīrtināth Jhā; Kedar Kanan; Kumār Manīś Arvind; Ujjval Kumār Jhā; Āśīṣ Ancinhār (multiple essays); Lakṣmaṇ Jhā Sāgar; Pravīṇ Kumār Jhā; Nārāyaṇ Jhā; Dr. Kailāś Kumār Miśra; Bhīmnāth Jhā.]

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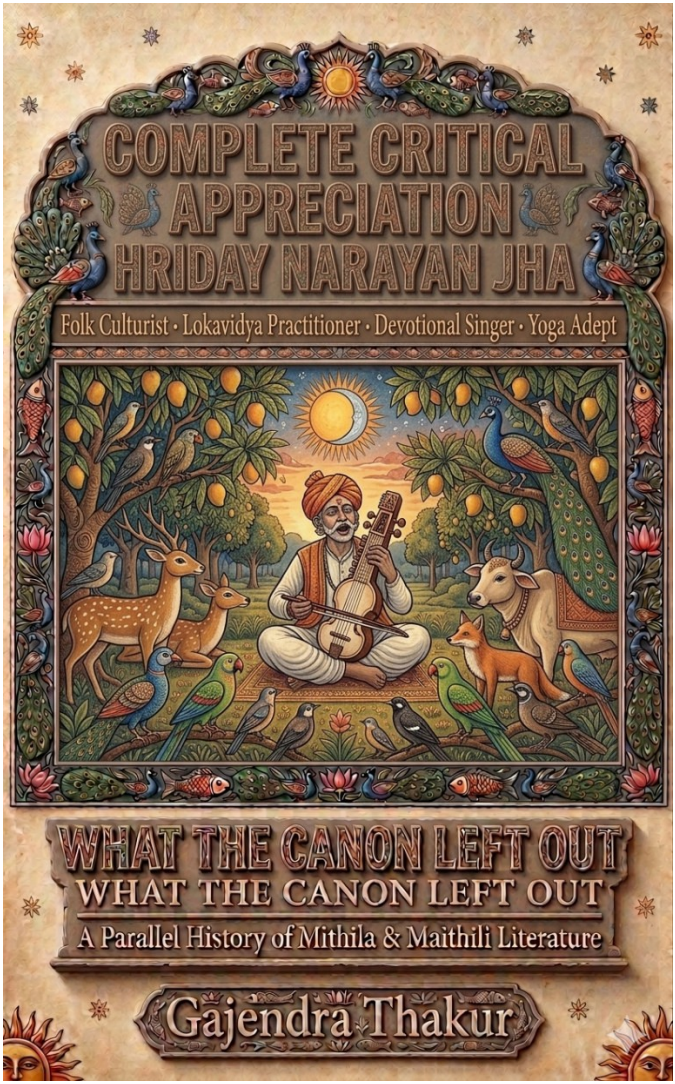
**LESSON 027 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**



# COMPLETE CRITICAL APPRECIATION

# HRIDAY NARAYAN JHA

*Folk Culturist · Lokavidya Practitioner · Devotional Singer · Yoga Adept*

*Indian & Western Literary Theory · Videha Parallel History Framework*
*Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa · Rasa-Dhvani-Vakrokti-Auchitya*

## I. BIOGRAPHICAL PROFILE

### A. Identity and Institutional Affiliation

Hriday Narayan Jha (हृदय नारायण झा) is a Maithili cultural practitioner, folk musicologist, and devotional artist whose primary institutional affiliation, as documented in the Videha Sadeha 1 archive, is as a B High Grade artist of All India Radio (आकाशवाणीक बी हाइग्रेड कलाकार). The All India Radio (AIR/Akashvani) grading system for artists — which ranks performers as A Top, A, B High, B, and C grades on the basis of auditions assessing technical competence, artistic quality, and cultural significance — places Yadava's B High Grade certification as a mark of substantial professional recognition within the broadcast cultural institution. For a folk and devotional artist working in the Maithili tradition, this grading represents formal institutional validation of a practice that might otherwise remain confined to the living oral tradition.

His second defining qualification, noted in the same archive entry, is the receipt of traditional yoga education (परम्परागत योगक शिक्षा प्राप्त) — not yoga in the modern fitness sense but in the lineage-based disciplinary sense of the classical Indian tradition, suggesting connection to a guru-paramparā (teacher lineage) in the yogic tradition of Mithila. This dual formation — as broadcast folk artist and as practitioner of traditional yoga — marks Hriday Narayan Jha as a figure who inhabits the intersection of the oral-performative and the contemplative-ascetic dimensions of Mithila's cultural life.

His geographic and cultural base is the Madhubani region of Mithila — the heartland of Maithili folk culture, home to the Madhubani painting tradition,

the Koshi river culture, and the dense network of Shakta and Shaiva religious sites documented in his essay. His essay's rich knowledge of specific pilgrimage sites — Durgasthan in Madhubani, Bhadrakali in Koilakh, Buḍhī Māī in Mangarauni, Rājarājeśvarī in Ḍokhara, Siddhakāli in Jitvarpur, Parameshvarī in Ṭhāṛhī, and dozens more — reflects intimate local knowledge of sacred geography that belongs to the practitioner rather than to the external observer.

## B. Position in the Videha Community

Hriday Narayan Jha appears in the Videha Sadeha 1 (विदेह सदेह १) — the first collected edition of the Videha eJournal, dated 1 January 2009, representing Videha's first two years of publication (2007–2009). His inclusion in this foundational volume, alongside figures such as Gajendra Thakur, Udaya Narayan Singh 'Nachiketa', Ramananand Jha 'Raman', Gangesh Gunjan, Mayanand Mishra, Ravindra Kumar Das, and dozens of other Maithili writers and intellectuals, places him within the core Videha community from its earliest phase.

The Videha Sadeha 1 is not merely a periodical collection but an archival monument — the first digital compilation of the first Maithili internet journal, consciously constructing a parallel literary history outside the Sahitya Akademi mainstream. Hriday Narayan Jha's contribution to this volume — his essay on endangered Maithili folk songs — is thus not a peripheral or occasional contribution but a foundational one: it establishes, from the very beginning of the Videha archive, the journal's commitment to the documentation of the oral-folk-performative dimensions of Maithili culture that the print-canonical tradition has systematically neglected.

The same essay appears in Videha Sadeha 30 (Prelim_30) at pages 1154–1183, confirming that his work was considered significant enough to be included in a subsequent Sadeha collected edition covering material from issues 1–350. This dual appearance — in Sadeha 1 and Sadeha 30 — represents a notable degree of archival longevity within the Videha corpus.

# II. WORKS: COMPLETE CATALOGUE AND ANNOTATION

## A. Primary Documented Work

'लुप्तप्राय मैथिली लोकगीत' (Luptraprāya Maithilī Lokagīta / Endangered Maithili Folk Songs)

Published in: Videha Sadeha 1 (file 84.doc), January 2009; also archived in Videha Sadeha 30 (Prelim_30, pages 1154–1183). Source: Videha digital archive (ISSN 2229-547X), www.videha.co.in.

This essay is Hriday Narayan Jha's major documented contribution to the Videha archive. It is a substantial work — spanning thirty pages in the Sadeha 30 compilation (pages 1154–1183) — that combines cultural advocacy, musicological documentation, religious-cultural history, and anthological presentation of folk songs. The essay's full title signals its orientation: it is not a celebration of a living tradition but a lament for an endangered one, and its purpose is simultaneously archival (to document what is being lost) and activist (to call for systematic preservation).

## B. Structure and Contents of 'Luptraprāya Maithilī Lokagīta'

### *Opening Thesis: The Urgency of Documentation*

The essay opens with a catalogue of endangered folk song genres: पराती (Parātī — dawn hymns), गोसाउनिक गीत (Gosāunik Gīta — household deity invocations), भगवतीगीत (Bhagavatīgīta — Shakti devotional songs), झूमरा (Jhūmarā — ritual invocation songs sung by bhagat communities), सोहर (Sohara — birth songs), खेलउना (Khelaunā — children's play songs), कुमार (Kumāra — youth initiation songs), परिछन (Parichana — threshold welcoming songs), चुमान (Cumāna — ceremonial touching songs), डहकन (Ḍahakana — lamentation songs), विषहारा गीत (Viṣahārā Gīta — snake-deity songs), झूमरि (Jhūmarī), बटगमनी (Baṭagamanī — wayfarer songs), मलार (Malāra — rainy season melodies), चैमासा (Caimāsā — four-month monsoon songs), लगनी (Laganī — wedding processional songs), समदाउन (Samadāuna — farewell

lament songs at marriage), and कोशी गीत (Koṣī Gīta — songs of the Koshi river culture).

This inventory is itself a significant scholarly contribution. No single Maithili genre catalogue of this comprehensiveness appears in the mainstream canonical literature. Each genre Jha names corresponds to a specific ritual occasion, seasonal cycle, or life-event within Maithili social life — the total picture is of a song culture so thoroughly embedded in the rhythms of daily, seasonal, and ceremonial life that its disappearance represents not merely an aesthetic loss but a rupture in the social fabric.

The call to action is precise: collect the songs from living practitioners while they still survive; document them in audio-video form (आॅडियो वीडियो रूप मे दस्तावेजीकरण); publish the texts. This three-part programme — collection, audio-visual documentation, publication — anticipates the modern UNESCO framework for intangible cultural heritage (ICH) safeguarding by several years in its practical specificity.

### *The Puranic Context: Mithila's Sacred Geography*

Before presenting the songs, Jha situates Maithili folk culture within the sacred geography of Mithila by citing the Brihad Vishnu Purana's verses on Mithila's sanctity: 'Dhanyāste ye prayatnena nivasanti mahātmune / Vicarenmithilā madhye grāme grāme vicakṣaṇaḥ' (Blessed are those who, O great sage, dwell in Mithila with effort, and wander village to village in Mithila). The citation of Sanskrit puranic authority to establish the cultural credentials of vernacular folk practice is a characteristic move of the Maithili traditional scholarly tradition — it places the folk song within a cosmological framework that validates its significance without subordinating it.

Jha then maps the sacred sites of Mithila — from Durgasthan in Madhubani through Bhadrakali, Buḍhī Māī, Rājarājeśvarī, Siddhakāli, Parameshvarī, Tarā Mandira, Ugrātārā, Caṇḍikā, Kātyāyanī, Kañkālī, Daśamahāvidyā shrines, Vanadurgā, Śyāmāmandira, Tārāsthāna, Cāmuṇḍā, Ahilyāsthāna, Śītalā Sthāna, Pūranadevi, Dakṣiṇakālikā, Tripurasundarī, Sakhleśvarī, Chhinnamasticā, Vairāṭī Devī, and many others — as the devotional context within which the Bhagavati songs and Gosaunik songs he presents emerged and survived.

This topographical inventory of Shakta shrines is itself a scholarly contribution of first importance: it documents the 'Shakti landscape' of Mithila in a systematic way, establishing that the devotional folk song tradition is not a

random collection of religious sentiment but a geographically specific tradition rooted in the particular Shakta sacred geography of the Maithili region.

### *The Nine Songs: Textual Documentation*

The heart of the essay presents nine devotional songs (Gosaunik Gīta / Bhagavati Gīta) in nine distinct tunes (नौ धुन), each attributed to a specific composer or marked as traditional (पारंपरिक):

1. Traditional Parātī: 'Prana rahata nahi mora Śyāma binu...' — a Krishnaite dawn hymn attributed to Sahebdas, in the Brajabhasha-influenced Maithili of the folk register, expressing the devotee's longing for the divine beloved.

2. Gosaunik Gīt (Traditional): 'Jay vara jay vara diā he gosāuni he mā tāriṇī tribhuvana devī...' — a Durga invocation in the Jhumra form, with onomatopoeic sound-symbolism ('Kaṭ kaṭ kaṭ maikā danta śabda kaeli') representing the goddess's manifestation.

3. Mahamahopādhyāya Madan Upadhyay: 'Jay jay tāriṇī bhava bhaya hāriṇī durita nivāriṇī vara māle...' — a classical Sanskrit-inflected Maithili hymn to the Tara goddess, in elaborate devotional strophes.

4. Traditional: 'Karu bhava sāgara pāra he jananī...' — a Bhakti surrender song ('Who is my boat, who is my boatman, who will take me across?') invoking the goddess as mother-ferryman.

5. Kālikānta: 'Akhila viśva ke naina tārā ahīṃ chī he jagadamba...' — a devotional song to the cosmic Mother in the Panchamī style, with elaborate nature imagery.

6–7. Traditional invocations of Kali/Jagadamba in the simple folk register ('He jagadamba jagata mātā kālī prathama praṇāma...', 'He ambe mātā hamaro para hoiyau sahāya...').

8. Mahākavi Vidyapati: 'Ādi bhavānī vinaya tua pāya...' — a Vidyapati composition to Bhavani/Kali, establishing the direct lineage from the greatest classical Maithili poet to the living folk tradition.

9. Kaviśvara Canda Jhā: 'Tua binu āja bhavana bhela re ghana vipina samāna...' — a composition by the 19th-century Maithili poet Canda Jhā, in the classical rāga-based form.

The inclusion of both anonymous traditional songs and named compositions by Sahebdas, Madan Upadhyay, Kālikānta, Vidyapati, and Canda Jhā demonstrates the full range of the Maithili devotional song tradition — from

high classical (Vidyapati) through 19th-century literary (Canda Jhā) through 20th-century composers (Madan Upadhyay, Kālikānta) to anonymous oral tradition. Jha's essay thus documents not a simple folk tradition but a multi-layered cultural practice that incorporates classical, semi-classical, and purely oral elements within a single living tradition.

### *The Jhumra Documentation*

The essay's second major documentation is of the Jhumra tradition — the ritual invocation songs sung by a bhagat (possessed devotee) community of nine members (नौ सदस्यक समवेत स्वर मे), accompanied by the jhāli (cymbal) and māṃḍara (drum). The bhagat's body becomes the vehicle for the goddess's manifestation (भगतक शरीर मे देवी प्रगट होइत छथि), making the Jhumra not merely a song but a ritual of divine possession and community worship.

Jha's source for the Jhumra song is named: Batahū Yādava, a bhagat who is himself worried about the tradition's survival ('बतहू यादव सन भगत चिन्तित छथि जे हुनक बाद ई परंपरा कोना बाँचत?'). This named testimony — the practitioner's own anxiety about the tradition's continuity — gives the documentation a particular poignancy and specificity. Jha's role as cultural advocate is made explicit: he is the amanuensis for Batahū Yādava's song, the mediating scribe between the oral performance and the written archive.

The Jhumra text presented begins: 'Arahī je vana se maiyā kharahī kaṭaolaiyai he maiyā...' (From the arhar [pigeonpea] forest, the Mother cut the stubble-grass...) — a narrative of the goddess building her dwelling from forest materials, rich in agricultural imagery drawn from the specific ecology of the Mithila Tarai.

## III. RASA, DHVANI, VAKROKTI: INDIAN LITERARY THEORY

### A. Rasa Analysis

The nine devotional songs Jha documents span multiple rasa-registers. The Krishnaite Parātī ('Prana rahata nahi mora Śyāma binu') embodies Śṛṅgāra-rasa (the erotic-devotional register) in its vipralambha (separation) mode — the devotee's longing for the absent divine beloved is simultaneously erotic and

mystical, employing the conventions of Maithili śṛṅgāra poetry established by Vidyapati in the 14th century. The Durga invocations employ Adbhuta-rasa (wonder) in their description of the goddess's manifestation ('Kaṭ kaṭ kaṭ maikā danta śabada kaeli / Gaṭ gaṭ giralani kāṃce' — the crackling sound of the raw skull the goddess devours), and Vīra-rasa (heroic register) in the imagery of battle and destruction of demons. The surrender songs ('Karu bhava sāgara pāra') employ Śānta-rasa (tranquillity) as their dominant register, but with undertones of Karuṇa (pathos) in the devotee's acknowledgment of ignorance and helplessness.

Bharatamuni's Nāṭyaśāstra (2nd century BCE–2nd century CE) establishes rasa as the essential quality of any aesthetic experience, constituted through the interplay of vibhāva (determinants), anubhāva (consequents), and sañcārī bhāva (transient states). In Jha's songs, the vibhāva is the ritual occasion (the gahbar — the sacred enclosure where the goddess is worshipped; the dawn; the wedding threshold); the anubhāva is the physical response (weeping, prostration, the bhagat's possession); and the sañcārī bhāva are the transient states of longing, wonder, surrender, and devotional ecstasy that move through the performance.

## B. Dhvani: The Resonance of the Folk Song

Ānandavardhana's Dhvanyāloka (9th century) establishes dhvani (suggestion, resonance) as the soul of poetry — the capacity of language to mean more than its literal content, to evoke a surplus of significance that the literal statement cannot exhaust. In the Gosaunik Gīta, the invocation 'Ke morā naiyā ke mora khevāyā ke morā utārata pāra he jananī' (Who is my boat, who is my boatman, who will take me across, O Mother?) operates at multiple levels simultaneously: literally as a request for the goddess's salvific intervention; symbolically as the metaphor of the ocean of saṃsāra (the world-cycle) and the need for divine grace to cross it; and existentially as the human condition of helplessness before the forces of birth, death, and suffering. The dhvani here is the unstated but resonant sense of the human being's fundamental inadequacy and the necessity of surrender — a meaning the literal statement gestures toward but cannot exhaust.

The Jhumra's imagery of the goddess building her dwelling from forest materials ('Arahī je vana se maiyā kharahī kaṭaolaiyai...') operates with agricultural dhvani: the pigeon-pea forest, the stubble-grass, the bamboo palace are specifics of the Mithila landscape that resonate with the entire agricultural culture of the region — the goddess is not a remote celestial figure but one who

inhabits and constructs her dwelling from the same materials that sustain the community's daily life.

### C. Vakrokti: Oblique Expression

Kuntaka's Vakroktijīvita (10th century) analyses vakrokti — oblique, indirect, or figural expression — as the essential quality of poetic language. In the Vidyapati devotional song ('Ādi bhavānī vinaya tua pāya / Tua sumirait durata dūra jāya'), vakrokti operates in the compression of the Tantric theology of the goddess into the devotional formula of personal prayer: the complex metaphysical reality of Shakta Tantra — the goddess as the source and destroyer of all phenomena — is expressed obliquely through the simple personal gesture of bowing and requesting grace. The lion-riding, skull-wearing, blood-drinking goddess of Tantric theology becomes, through vakrokti, simply 'Mā' — Mother — whose grace the devotee seeks. This compression of the cosmic into the intimate is vakrokti of the highest order.

### D. Auchitya: Propriety and Contextual Fitness

Kshemendra's Auchityavicāracarcā (11th century) establishes auchitya (contextual propriety) as the supreme principle of aesthetic evaluation. Jha's essay as a whole demonstrates auchitya in its structural choices: the puṇyaśloka citations from the Brihad Vishnu Purana establish the cosmic propriety of Mithila's cultural heritage; the topographic inventory of Shakti shrines establishes the geographic propriety of the devotional tradition; and the presentation of songs from multiple compositional registers (classical/Vidyapati, semi-classical/Canda Jhā, 20th-century devotional/Madan Upadhyay, anonymous oral tradition) establishes the historical propriety of the tradition's continuity. Each element is contextually appropriate to the essay's purpose as both cultural document and scholarly advocacy.

## IV. NAVYA-NYĀYA EPISTEMOLOGICAL ANALYSIS

### A. Śabda-Pramāṇa and the Authority of Folk Song

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's Tattvacintāmaṇi (c. 1325 CE, Mithila) analyses śabda (verbal testimony) as one of the four sources of valid knowledge (pramāṇa). For Gaṅgeśa, verbal testimony is valid when the speaker (vaktā) possesses both the

knowledge (jñāna) and the intention to communicate it honestly (tattvajñāna and vivakṣā). In the context of Hriday Narayan Jha's folk song documentation, śabda-pramāṇa operates at multiple levels. First, the songs themselves are instances of śabda-pramāṇa in the theological sense: they are the verbal testimony of the devotional tradition, transmitting knowledge of the goddess's nature and the devotee's proper relationship to her across generations. Second, Jha's documentation — including his named witness Batahū Yādava — is an exercise in śabda-pramāṇa in the scholarly sense: the reliable testimony of a practitioner-observer, whose insider status (as All India Radio folk artist and yoga practitioner) gives his testimony the aptness (āptatā) that Gaṅgeśa requires for valid verbal knowledge.

The crisis Jha documents — the threatened extinction of the folk song tradition — is, in Navya-Nyāya terms, a crisis of śabda-pramāṇa transmission: the unbroken chain of verbal testimony through which the tradition has been transmitted is being broken. When Batahū Yādava asks 'हुनक बाद इ परंपरा कोना बाँचत?' (How will this tradition survive after me?), he is asking precisely the epistemological question: how will the knowledge embedded in the songs be transmitted if the chain of testimony is severed? Jha's archival work is the written substitute for the oral chain — an attempt to preserve the śabda-pramāṇa through inscription when the living transmission is endangered.

## B. Pratyakṣa and Anumāna in Folk Song Analysis

Gaṅgeśa's analysis of pratyakṣa (direct perception) as the primary source of valid knowledge is relevant to Jha's position as a practitioner-analyst. His direct perception of the folk song tradition — as a performing artist (AIR B High Grade), as a yoga practitioner connected to traditional lineages, and as a Madhubani-region resident with intimate knowledge of the sacred geography — gives him access to a form of knowledge that external scholars lack. His hearing of the Jhumra from Batahū Yādava is not merely testimonial knowledge (śabda) but participatory perceptual knowledge (parokṣa-pratyakṣa) — the knowledge of one who has been present at the performance, who has heard the jhāli and māṃḍara, who has witnessed the bhagat's possession.

Anumāna (inference) also operates in Jha's essay in the form of the general argument from specific instances: from the observed fact that no young people are learning the traditional Gosaunik Gīt tunes (the hetu — reason), Jha infers the general danger of cultural extinction (the sādhya — the property to be established), via the vyāpti (universal concomitance): 'whenever a tradition's

transmission to the younger generation ceases, the tradition dies'. This is a straightforward but important inference — and Jha makes it explicitly, naming the pedagogical failure ('āwak nava pīṛhīk bīc ekara paramparāgata śikṣāk vyavahāra nahi dekhala jāicha') as the cause of the tradition's endangerment.

### C. Gaṅgeśa and the Geography of Knowledge

There is a profound geographical and cultural resonance in applying Gaṅgeśa's epistemological framework to Hriday Narayan Jha's work. Gaṅgeśa was born in Karion, Darbhanga district — the same Mithila heartland whose sacred geography Jha maps, whose folk songs he documents, and whose cultural crisis he laments. The Tattvacintāmaṇi was composed in the same culture — the Maithil Brahman intellectual culture of medieval Mithila — that produced Vidyapati, Canda Jhā, and the anonymous composers of the Parātī and Gosaunik Gīt. Jha's documentation of this living folk tradition is thus simultaneously a contribution to the Navya-Nyāya tradition's home culture — an act of knowledge (pramā) within the same epistemological community that Gaṅgeśa theorised.

## V. THE VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY FRAMEWORK

### A. Folk Culture and the Counter-Canon

The Videha Parallel History Framework, as constructed by Gajendra Thakur, insists that the democratic, pluralist, and institutionally independent Maithili tradition is the true living heritage of Mithila — a heritage that the Sahitya Akademi-centred canonical print literature has systematically marginalised. Hriday Narayan Jha's essay is a paradigm case for this framework. The nineteen genres of folk song he identifies — Parātī, Gosaunik Gīt, Sohara, Jhūmarā, Khelauna, Kumāra, Parichana, Cumāna, Ḍahakana, Viṣahārā Gīt, Bataganī, Malāra, Caimāsā, Laganī, Samadāuna, Koṣī Gīt, and others — represent forms of Maithili cultural expression that have no presence in the Sahitya Akademi's award lists, no representation in its canonical anthologies, and no recognition in its institutional structures.

Yet these are the forms that have sustained Maithili cultural identity across generations, that have marked every significant moment of Maithili social life (birth, marriage, death, harvest, monsoon, dawn), and that constitute the living

practice of Maithili culture for the vast majority of its speakers. The Sahitya Akademi canon — with its emphasis on print-published novels, poetry collections, and critical essays by educated, urban, upper-caste male authors — represents a tiny fraction of the actual Maithili cultural universe. Jha's essay documents the rest of that universe.

## B. Batahū Yādava and the Subaltern Voice

The figure of Batahū Yādava — the bhagat from whom Jha records the Jhumra song, and who voices his anxiety about the tradition's survival — is itself a significant Parallel History moment. Batahū Yādava is a practitioner of a ritual tradition of spirit possession and communal devotional singing; he is unnamed in the canonical literary histories; he is almost certainly from a non-Brahman community (the bhagat tradition of Jhumra performance is associated with specific caste communities of Mithila). His voice — preserved in Jha's essay as a named witness and a documented practitioner — is the kind of subaltern voice that the Parallel History Framework is designed to record and validate.

Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's question 'Can the subaltern speak?' (1988) is directly relevant here. In the canonical literary history, Batahū Yādava cannot speak — he has no platform, no print publication, no institutional affiliation. In the Videha archive, through Jha's mediation, he does speak — his song is preserved, his name is recorded, his anxiety is documented. The Parallel History's insistence on the value of testimonial, oral, and performative cultural expression over the hegemony of print gives Batahū Yādava a form of textual existence that the canonical tradition denies him.

## C. Vidyapati's Continuity

One of the most significant structural features of Jha's essay is the inclusion of a Vidyapati composition ('Ādi bhavānī vinaya tua pāya...') within the collection of living folk songs alongside anonymous traditional songs and 20th-century compositions. This inclusion asserts a continuity between the 14th-century classical tradition and the contemporary folk tradition — a continuity that the canonical literary history severs by treating Vidyapati as a classical-literary figure whose work belongs to the Sanskrit-influenced high tradition rather than to the living oral culture.

The Videha Parallel History Framework consistently insists on the continuity between the Adi Kavi (Pre-Jyotirishwar Vidyapati), Vidyapati Thakkurah (1350–1435), and the democratic oral tradition that has transmitted their legacy. Jha's essay performs this continuity in practice: the Vidyapati devotional song

lives alongside the anonymous Jhumra in the same community of practice, sung by the same performers, in the same ritual contexts. The canon's separation of 'literary Vidyapati' from 'folk Vidyapati' is a scholarly fiction that the living tradition repudiates.

## VI. WESTERN CRITICAL AND ETHNOMUSICOLOGICAL FRAMEWORKS

### A. Walter Benjamin: The Oral Tradition and Its Endangerment

Walter Benjamin's essay 'The Storyteller' (1936) analyses the decline of oral storytelling in the face of modernity — the print novel, mass media, and the disruption of craft-based communal life. Benjamin argues that the oral tradition transmits not merely information but 'experience' (Erfahrung) in the full sense — accumulated wisdom embedded in narrative, connected to the rhythms of community life. The threat to the Maithili folk song that Jha documents is precisely Benjamin's story: the traditional practitioner community is losing its transmission mechanism, not because the tradition lacks value but because the conditions of modernity (urbanisation, migration, mass media, the declining economic viability of traditional community life) have disrupted the social infrastructure that sustained it. Jha's documentation project is a Benjaminian response: an attempt to preserve the content of the tradition even when the experiential conditions that generated it can no longer be maintained.

### B. Bruno Nettl: Ethnomusicology and Cultural Change

Bruno Nettl's work on ethnomusicology and cultural change — particularly The Study of Ethnomusicology (1983) and Heartland Excursions (1995) — provides a framework for understanding the specific dynamics of Jha's documentation project. Nettl distinguishes between 'maintenance' (the preservation of a tradition in its original form), 'gradual change' (the adaptation of a tradition to new circumstances), and 'abandonment' (the loss of a tradition). Jha's essay is concerned precisely with the distinction between gradual change and abandonment: he notes that Bhagavati songs are now being sung to filmi (Bollywood) tunes rather than traditional ones ('filmī gītaka dhuna me bhagavatī gīta sabhak calana') — a form of gradual change that may ultimately lead to abandonment, since the specific melodic identities (dhuna) of the traditional songs are as much part of the tradition as the texts.

Nettl's concept of the 'musical canon' — the set of works regarded as exemplary within a tradition — is relevant to Jha's multi-register presentation. By including Vidyapati, Canda Jhā, Madan Upadhyay, Kālikānta, Sahebdas, and anonymous traditional songs side by side, Jha implicitly proposes a folk-devotional canon that is more inclusive and more representative of the actual practice of Maithili musical culture than the print-literary canon.

## C. Gramsci: Folklore and Hegemony

Antonio Gramsci's analysis of folklore (Prison Notebooks, 1929–1935) argues that folk culture — including folk song, folk belief, and popular tradition — represents 'a conception of the world and of life, implicit in the main, of certain strata of society in opposition to, or different from, those of the leading groups' (PN, III, 2311). For Gramsci, folklore is not a pre-modern survival but a form of subaltern cultural resistance — the expression of the worldview of those who do not control the dominant institutions.

Jha's folk songs — particularly the Jhumra tradition associated with non-Brahmin bhagat communities and the anonymous communal songs of the agricultural calendar — are Gramscian folklore in this precise sense: they express a cosmology, a social ethic, and a relationship to the sacred that is distinct from (and often at odds with) the Brahminical Sanskrit-scriptural tradition that the Maithili canonical establishment has privileged. The goddess who 'builds her palace from forest materials' is not the goddess of the Puranic high tradition but the goddess of the Mithila peasant's agricultural universe.

## D. UNESCO Intangible Cultural Heritage Framework

Jha's documentation programme — collect, audio-visually document, publish — directly anticipates the UNESCO Convention for the Safeguarding of the Intangible Cultural Heritage (2003), which defines ICH as including 'oral traditions and expressions, including language as a vehicle of the intangible cultural heritage; performing arts; social practices, rituals and festive events; knowledge and practices concerning nature and the universe; traditional craftsmanship'. The Maithili folk songs Jha documents fall squarely within all five of these categories simultaneously: they are oral expressions, performing arts, social practices/rituals, and knowledge about nature and the universe (the agricultural calendar, the Koshi river ecology, the Shakta sacred geography of Mithila).

The UNESCO framework requires 'communities, groups and, in some cases, individuals' to be recognized as bearers of ICH. Jha's naming of Batahū Yādava

as a community bearer, and his own role as AIR B High Grade folk artist, are precisely the kinds of 'bearer community' recognition that the UNESCO framework mandates. His essay is, avant la lettre, an ICH safeguarding document.

## VII. CRITICAL SYNTHESIS: SIGNIFICANCE AND LEGACY

Hriday Narayan Jha's contribution to the Videha archive, while constituting a single major essay, is of disproportionate significance within the Parallel History Framework. Several dimensions of this significance deserve emphasis.

First, the essay's taxonomic contribution. The nineteen genres of Maithili folk song that Jha identifies and names — Parātī, Gosaunik Gīt, Bhagavatī Gīt, Jhūmarā, Sohara, Khelauna, Kumāra, Parichana, Cumāna, Ḍahakana, Viṣahārā Gīt, Jhūmarī, Baṭagamanī, Malāra, Caimāsā, Laganī, Samadāuna, Koṣī Gīt, and others — constitute the most comprehensive genre catalogue of Maithili folk songs in the Videha archive. No equivalent taxonomy exists in the canonical Maithili literary scholarship.

Second, the essay's archival contribution. The nine devotional songs presented — in nine distinct tunes, from five different composers/traditions — constitute a primary-source anthology of Maithili Gosaunik and Bhagavatī Gīt that preserves texts and compositional attributions that would otherwise be lost. The Jhumra text from Batahū Yādava is, as far as can be determined from the Videha archive, a unique transcription of an oral performance.

Third, the essay's advocacy contribution. Jha's explicit call for audio-visual documentation and publication of endangered folk songs was, at the time of its 2009 Videha publication, ahead of mainstream institutional practice in India. The subsequent expansion of UNESCO's ICH safeguarding framework and the Indian government's documentation programmes has vindicated his approach.

Fourth, the essay's theoretical contribution. Jha's implicit argument — that the Maithili folk song tradition constitutes a coherent cultural system encompassing agricultural, seasonal, ritualistic, devotional, and cosmological knowledge — anticipates the ethnomusicological and cultural studies approaches that have since gained ground in South Asian studies. His multi-register anthology (classical/Vidyapati, literary/Canda Jhā, devotional/Madan Upadhyay, oral/traditional) implicitly proposes a continuity theory of Maithili

musical culture that is more sophisticated than the canonical separation of 'classical' from 'folk'.

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FOLK SONG ANALYSIS

**HRIDAY NARAYAN JHA**

हृदय नारायण झा

*लुप्तप्राय मैथिली लोकगीत: Close Reading and Cultural Analysis*

*Indian & Western Literary Theory · Videha Parallel History Framework*

*Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa · Rasa-Dhvani-Vakrokti-Auchitya*

# I. 'LUPTRAPRĀYA MAITHILĪ LOKAGĪTA' AS LITERARY-CULTURAL FORM

## A. The Endangered Archive Essay

Hriday Narayan Jha's 'Luptraprāya Maithilī Lokagīta' (लुप्तप्राय मैथिली लोकगीत — Endangered Maithili Folk Songs) belongs to a distinct genre of Maithili cultural writing that one might call the 'endangered archive essay' — a form that combines cultural advocacy, ethnographic documentation, textual anthology, and scholarly argument in a single discursive structure. This genre, while not formally named in Maithili literary criticism, has precedents in the

documentation work of earlier Maithili cultural historians, but Jha's essay is distinguished by its combination of generic breadth, topographic specificity, and named-practitioner testimony.

The essay's discursive structure moves through four phases: (1) the taxonomic — listing the genres at risk; (2) the contextual — establishing Mithila's sacred geography and puranic authority; (3) the anthological — presenting representative songs from multiple traditions; and (4) the archival-advocacy — naming endangered practitioners and calling for systematic documentation. Each phase performs a distinct rhetorical function, but all four are unified by the essay's central argument: that the loss of these songs is not merely a cultural loss but an epistemological one — the erasure of forms of knowledge (about agricultural seasons, ritual practice, divine cosmology, and community ethics) that are encoded nowhere else.

## B. Intertextuality: The Essay and Its Sources

The essay operates across three distinct registers of Maithili cultural authority. The first is Puranic: the Brihad Vishnu Purana's Sanskrit verses on Mithila establish the cosmic-religious framework within which the folk songs are situated. The second is classical literary: Vidyapati's devotional composition ('Ādi bhavānī') and Kaviśvara Canda Jhā's song ('Tua binu āja bhavana bhela re') are cited as representative of the classical-literary tradition's continuity with the folk. The third is oral-communal: the anonymous Parātī ('Prana rahata nahi mora'), the traditional Gosaunik Gīta, and the Jhumra from Batahū Yādava represent the living oral tradition. This three-register intertextuality — Puranic, classical-literary, oral-communal — is a characteristic feature of Maithili cultural scholarship in the tradition that Jha represents: the refusal to separate the sacred, the literary, and the popular.

## C. Prose Style

Jha's prose style in this essay is that of the educated Maithili cultural insider writing for a community audience rather than for an academic journal. The sentences are relatively short and direct; the vocabulary blends Sanskrit-derived terms (paramparā, dastāvejīkaraṇa, saṃskāra) with colloquial Maithili; and the rhetorical mode is primarily descriptive and exhortatory rather than argumentative. This is entirely appropriate to the essay's purpose: it is addressed to the Videha readership — a community of Maithili cultural practitioners and enthusiasts — rather than to a specialist scholarly audience.

The essay's effectiveness as advocacy depends on its accessibility and on the directness of its emotional appeal to the reader's sense of cultural loss.

## II. THE GENRE TAXONOMY: A SYSTEMATIC ANALYSIS

### A. Life-Cycle Songs

The life-cycle songs documented by Jha — Sohara (birth songs), Khelauna (children's play songs), Kumāra (youth songs), Parichana (threshold welcoming songs), Cumāna (ceremonial touching songs), and Laganī (wedding processional songs) — constitute a complete set of ritual accompaniments to the transitions of Maithili social life from birth to marriage. Each genre is functionally specific: the Sohara celebrates and sanctifies the birth; the Khelauna accompanies children's early socialisation; the Kumāra marks the transition from childhood to youth; the Parichana and Cumāna accompany the ceremonial arrival of the bride at the threshold of her new home; and the Laganī accompanies the wedding procession itself.

The loss of these genres is not merely the loss of songs but the loss of the ritual occasions that gave them meaning. When the Sohara is no longer sung at a birth, the birth is no longer ritually framed within the Maithili cosmological tradition; when the Laganī is replaced by a film song at a wedding procession, the wedding procession is no longer a moment in the specifically Maithili ritual tradition but a generic modern event. Jha's anxiety about these losses is therefore an anxiety about the dissolution of Maithili social-ritual identity.

### B. Agricultural and Seasonal Songs

The seasonal songs — Malāra (monsoon-onset melodies), Caimāsā (four-month monsoon cycle songs), Samadāuna (farewell lament associated with the monsoon season and with daughters' departures), and Koṣī Gīta (songs of the Koshi river culture) — encode agricultural and ecological knowledge in musical form. The Malāra (from the Sanskrit malāra/malhāra rāga) is associated with the onset of the monsoon, its melody evoking the specific emotional quality of the pre-monsoon and monsoon atmosphere — the relief of rain after summer heat, the anxiety about floods, the beauty of dark clouds over the paddy fields. The Caimāsā covers the four-month period of monsoon (āṣāḍha through āśvina) during which the agricultural year is most intensive.

The Koṣī Gīta is perhaps the most culturally specific of Jha's genres. The Koshi river — known historically as the 'Sorrow of Bihar' for its catastrophic floods — has a distinct culture, ecology, and mythology that has generated its own musical tradition. Songs associated specifically with the Koshi, its floods, its fish, its ecological rhythms, and its mythological identity (the Koshi as the daughter of Shiva in some traditions) constitute a distinctive sub-tradition within Maithili folk music that is doubly endangered: by the general decline of folk music practice and by the physical transformation of the Koshi's ecology through embankment and river management.

### C. Ritual Invocation Songs

The ritual invocation songs — Parātī (dawn hymns), Gosaunik Gīta/Bhagavatī Gīta (household deity invocations), Jhūmarā (possessed-devotee invocations), Viṣahārā Gīta (snake-deity songs), Jhūmarī, and Baṭagamanī — form the most sacred and most endangered cluster within Jha's taxonomy. These are not merely aesthetic performances but functional rituals: the Parātī is sung at dawn to wake the household and begin the day under divine protection; the Gosaunik Gīta invokes the household goddess at the beginning of any auspicious activity; the Jhūmarā is the vehicle through which the bhagat community channels the goddess's presence into the community's ritual space.

The Viṣahārā Gīta — songs addressed to the snake-goddess Viṣahārī (Mansa/Manasā in Bengal) — constitutes a tradition closely connected to the agricultural year and the threat of snakebite during the monsoon. The Mansa tradition in eastern India has generated an entire literary genre (the Maṅgalakāvya — auspicious narrative poems), of which the Maithili Viṣahārā Gīta is the oral-performative equivalent. The near-disappearance of these songs is connected to the decline of both the agricultural lifestyle that made snakebite a constant threat and the shamanic-folk-religious practice that addressed that threat through ritual song.

## III. THE NINE GOSAUNIK SONGS: CLOSE READING

### A. Song 1: Parātī — 'Ajahuṃ bhajana cita ceta mugudha mana'

अजहुँ भजन चित चेत मुगुध मन अजहु भजन चित चेत ।।

बालापन तरूणापन बीतल, केस भये सभ सेत मुगुध मन ।।

जा मुख राम नाम ने आबत, मानहु सो जन प्रेत मुगुध मन ।।

साहेबदास तोहि क्या लागत, राम नाम मुख लेत मुगुध मन ।।

Attributed to Sahebdas. This Parātī is composed in the Brajabhasha-Maithili mixed register characteristic of medieval devotional composition in the Mithila region. The refrain 'mugudha mana' (O deluded/bewildered mind) establishes the Bhakti tradition's characteristic rhetorical address — the poet speaking to his own mind as if to an errant pupil.

Rasa: Śānta-rasa (tranquillity born of spiritual insight) is the dominant rasa, but it is arrived at through the recognition of previous spiritual failure — the three middle verses catalogue the stages of a life wasted without bhajana (devotional practice): childhood (bālapana), youth (taruṇāpana), and the final stage signalled by whitened hair (kesa bhaye sabha seta). This temporal movement — from youth through age to death (the one who does not take Ram's name is likened to a preta, a ghost/corpse) — generates Karuṇa-rasa (pathos) as a sañcārī (transient emotion) before resolution in the śānta of the final verse's gentle self-admonishment.

Dhvani: The dawn performance context of the Parātī creates a dhvani of renewal and urgency: the song is sung at the threshold of a new day, and its message — 'even now, wake up' (ajahuṃ) — resonates with the literal awakening of the physical body and household as a metaphor for the spiritual awakening the song advocates. The sunrise (which the Parātī accompanies) is the unstated but resonant symbol.

Navya-Nyāya: The song's logic is an anumāna (inference): the hetu (reason) is 'childhood and youth have passed, the hair has whitened'; the sādhya (property to be established) is 'the time for spiritual practice is now urgently required'; the vyāpti (universal concomitance) is 'those who do not take Ram's name before death become ghosts'. The song's emotional power derives precisely from this inferential structure: the inference is so clear, so universally acknowledged, and yet so universally ignored.

### B. Song 2: Traditional Gosaunik Gīta — Durga Invocation

जय वर जय वर दिअ हे गोसाउनि हे मा तारिणी त्रिभुवन देवी ।

सिंह चढल मैया फिरथि गोसाउनि हे मा अतिबल भगवती चण्डी ।।

कट कट कट मैया दन्त शबद कएलि हे मा गट गट गिरलनि काँचे ।

घट घट घट मैया शोणित पिबलनि हे मा मातलि योगिन संगे ।।

This anonymous traditional Gosaunik Gīt invokes Durgā/Caṇḍī in her most ferocious Tantric form. The onomatopoeia of the third verse — 'Kaṭa kaṭa kaṭa maikā danta śabada kaeli / Gaṭa gaṭa giralani kāṃce / Ghaṭa ghaṭa ghaṭa maikā śoṇita pibalani' (Ka-ka-ka the Mother made the sound of gnashing teeth / gulp-gulp she swallowed them raw / gulp-gulp-gulp the Mother drank the blood) — is among the most striking sound-figures in Maithili folk poetry.

This is vakrokti of the sonic register: the onomatopoeic syllables 'kaṭa kaṭa kaṭa', 'gaṭa gaṭa', and 'ghaṭa ghaṭa ghaṭa' are not merely descriptive but performative — they enact in sound the visceral reality of the goddess's consuming power, making the auditor's body feel the violence they describe. This is the folk tradition's mastery of the resources of Tantric śabda-brahman — language as embodied power, not merely referential sign.

Rasa: Adbhuta (wonder) and Bhayānaka (terror) in complex interplay — the goddess is simultaneously terrifying (blood-drinking, demon-eating) and benevolent (tāriṇī — the one who delivers/ferries across). This dual rasa-structure reflects the Tantric theology of the goddess as both destroyer and sustainer, a theology that the simple folk song encodes more directly and more powerfully than many a learned Tantric text.

### C. Song 3: Mahāmahopādhyāya Madan Upadhyay — Hymn to Tārā

जय जय तारिणी भव भय हारिणी दुरित निवारिणी वर माले ।

परम स्वरूपिणी उग्र विभूषिणी दनुज विदूषिणी अहिमाले ।।

This composition by Mahāmahopādhyāya Madan Upadhyay is in the highly Sanskritised register of learned devotional poetry. The cascade of compound epithets — tāriṇī (deliverer), bhavabhayahāriṇī (remover of the fear of worldly existence), duritanivāriṇī (remover of sin), ugravibhūṣiṇī (adorned with fierce ornaments), danujvidūṣiṇī (destroyer of demons) — follows the Sanskrit alaṃkāra tradition of multiple-attribute invocation. Yet it is sung in the same

devotional community context as the anonymous folk songs, demonstrating the multi-register character of Maithili devotional culture.

The title Mahāmahopādhyāya (the highest traditional scholarly title in the Sanskrit pandit system) signals that Madan Upadhyay was a figure of the traditional learned class — yet his compositions entered the folk tradition and were transmitted through communal oral performance alongside anonymous songs. This dissolution of the boundary between 'learned' and 'folk' within the devotional context is a feature that the Videha Parallel History Framework consistently underscores as characteristic of the democratic Maithili cultural tradition.

### D. Songs 4–7: Traditional Surrender Songs

करू भव सागर पार हे जननी करू भवसागर पार ।

के मोरा नैया के मोर खेबैया के मोरा उतारत पार हे जननी ।।

अहीं मोर नैया अहीं मोर खेबइया अहीं उतारब पार हे जननी ।।

These four traditional invocations (songs 4–7) share the mode of absolute surrender and the rhetoric of helplessness — 'I do not know prayer, I do not know worship, I only know how to sing incoherent songs' (nahi jānī hama pūjā japa tapa / aṭapaṭa gīta gabai chī he); 'I am a fool from birth to birth' (janama janama sāṃo murūkha banala chī). This rhetoric of the devotee's profound inadequacy — combining Bhakti's characteristic self-deprecation with the maternal address to the goddess as the one who accepts even the incoherent song of the fool — constitutes a specific Maithili vernacular Bhakti theology.

Auchitya analysis: The contextual propriety of these songs is inseparable from their performance occasion. Sung in the gahbar (the sacred enclosure) during the night-long worship, in the presence of the goddess's image, by a community of worshippers who may include the most and least educated members of the village, the rhetoric of universal inadequacy ('I do not know' — 'hama ta kichu ne janai chī') creates communal solidarity: it is a theology of levelling, in which scholarly knowledge and folk practice are equally inadequate before the divine, and only sincere devotion (bhāva) matters.

### E. Song 8: Vidyapati — 'Ādi bhavānī vinaya tua pāya'

आदि भवानी विनय तुअ पाय, तुअ सुमिरइत दुरत दूर जाय ।।

सिंह चढ़ल देवि देल परवेश बघछाल पहिरन जोगिन भेष ।।

बाम लेल खपर दहिन लेल काति, असुर के बधए चललि निशि राति ।।

तुअ भल छाज देवि मुण्डहार, नूपूर शबद करए छनकार ।।

भनई विद्यापति कालीकेलि सदा ए रहू मैया दहिन भेलि ।।

This Vidyapati composition — identified by the signature verse 'Bhanai Vidyapati Kālikeli' — is one of his devotional songs to Kali/Bhavani rather than to Krishna, demonstrating the full range of Vidyapati's devotional output. The goddess here is described in her Tantric iconography with precise ritual accuracy: lion-mount (siṃha caḍhala), tiger-skin garment (bagachāla pahirana), yoginī form, skull-cup in the left hand (bāma lela khapara), sword in the right (dahina lela kāti), decapitated demon-heads as garland (muṇḍahāra), anklet-bells (nūpura śabada).

The inclusion of this Vidyapati composition by Jha — within a collection of folk songs addressed to the Maithili cultural community — asserts the unbroken continuity of Maithili devotional culture from the 14th century to the 21st. Vidyapati's song did not remain in scholarly editions; it entered the folk singing tradition and has been transmitted through oral performance in the same gahbar-worship context as the anonymous traditional songs alongside which Jha presents it. This is the Parallel History's living demonstration: the 'classical' and the 'folk' are not separate traditions but a single continuous practice.

### F. Song 9: Kaviśvara Canda Jhā — 'Tua binu āja bhavana bhela re'

तुअ बिनु आज भवन भेल रे घन विपिन समान ।।

जनु रिधि सिधिक गरूअ गेल रे मन होइछ भान ।।

परमेश्वरी महिमा तुअ रे जग के नहि जान ।

मोर अपराध छेमब सब रे नहि याचब आन ।।

जगत जननी काँ जग कह रे जन जानकि नाम ।

नहर नेह नियत नित रे रह मिथिला धाम ।।

This composition by Kaviśvara Canda Jhā (1844–1907) — the great 19th-century Maithili poet best known for his epic Rāmāyaṇa — is in a more personal, elegiac register than the formal Puranic invocations. The first verse's image of the house becoming like a 'dense forest' (ghana vipina) in the goddess's absence is a striking vakrokti: the domesticity of the 'bhavana' (home/household shrine) transformed into the wildness of the forest signals the dissolution of civilised order in the absence of the divine. The last verse's identification of 'Jānakī' (Sita, born in Mithila) with the goddess ('Jagat jananī kāṃ jaga kaha re / Jana jānaki nāma') is a specifically Mithila theological move: the connection between Sita and the Shakti goddess tradition, between Mithila's most famous daughter and the cosmic Mother, collapses the distance between myth and the local, making the divine specifically Maithili.

## IV. THE JHUMRA TRADITION: RITUAL PERFORMANCE ANALYSIS

### A. The Bhagat Community and Possession Ritual

The Jhumra performance tradition described by Jha — nine-member singing group, cymbal and drum accompaniment, the bhagat's body as the vessel of divine manifestation — belongs to the category of ritual possession performance that anthropologists, following Victor Turner's work on ritual structure and liminality ('The Ritual Process', 1969), identify as 'liminal' practice: performance at the threshold between the ordinary social world and the sacred, in which the normal social categories (caste, gender, age) are temporarily suspended or inverted to allow the divine presence to manifest.

Turner's analysis of 'communitas' — the temporary dissolution of social hierarchy in ritual performance, creating a direct horizontal bond among participants — is directly applicable to the Jhumra. In the gahbar, the bhagat (often from a non-Brahmin community) becomes the vessel of the goddess and thus the ritual authority of the occasion, inverting the normal social hierarchy in which the Brahmin priest controls religious ritual. This ritual inversion is encoded in the social practice of the tradition, and its threatened disappearance represents not merely a loss of musical form but a loss of the socially equalising ritual space that the Jhumra creates.

### B. The Jhumra Song: Ecological Imagery

अरही जे वन से मइया खरही कटओलियइ हे मइया खरही कटओलियइ हे ।

मइया जी हे बिजुबन कटओलियइ बिट बाँस जगदम्बा रचि रचि महल बनओलियई हे ।।

गोड़लागूँ पैयाँ पड़ूँ मइया जगदम्बा आइ मइया गहबर अबियउ हे ।

मइया जी हे राखि लिअउ भगत केर लाज जगदम्बा कलजोरि पैयाँ पड़इ छी हे ।।

The Jhumra text presents the goddess in her most intimately ecological form: she is not the cosmic destroyer of the Sanskrit Puranas but a being who lives in and is built from the specific landscape of Mithila. The arhar (pigeonpea) forest, the kharahi (stubble-grass), the bijuban (lightning-struck forest), the bāṃsa (bamboo) — these are the specific agricultural and ecological materials of the Mithila Tarai, and from them the goddess constructs her dwelling. The 'mahala' (palace) built from bamboo and stubble-grass is a folk-ecological palace, built from the same materials that the Mithila farmer uses to construct his own dwelling.

This ecological grounding of the divine is the folk tradition's most profound theological contribution: it refuses the transcendence of the Puranic cosmos and insists on the divine's immanence in the specific place, ecology, and agriculture of Mithila. The goddess does not reside in a celestial realm but in the arhar forest that borders the field, in the bamboo grove beside the tank, in the gahbar built of the same materials as the farmer's threshing floor.

Koṣī Gīt context: The ecological specificity of the Jhumra is continuous with the Koṣī Gīta tradition — the songs of the Koshi river culture — that Jha mentions in his opening genre catalogue. Both traditions encode the specific landscape of the Mithila Tarai as the primary site of the divine's presence, and both are endangered by the same forces: urbanisation, agricultural change, and the replacement of ecological knowledge by abstracted religious practice disconnected from the specific landscape.

# V. INTEGRATED THEORETICAL ASSESSMENT

## A. The Semiotic Structure of the Folk Song

Roland Barthes' distinction between 'denotation' and 'connotation' (Mythologies, 1957; Elements of Semiology, 1964) is useful for analysing the structural complexity of the songs Jha documents. At the denotative level, the songs are requests for the goddess's intervention in specific circumstances (deliverance from worldly suffering, blessing of the household, protection from demons). At the connotative level, they encode complex theological, cosmological, and social meanings: the four-level cosmology of the Puranas, the Tantric theology of the goddess as both destroyer and sustainer, the Bhakti tradition's levelling of social hierarchy through devotional surrender, and the specifically Maithili ecological theology that grounds the divine in the landscape.

The Jhumra adds a third level: the performative. At this level, the song is not merely a sign (denotation) or a signifier of cultural meaning (connotation) but an act — it brings the goddess into presence, it makes the ritual space a site of divine manifestation, it transforms the bhagat's body into the goddess's vehicle. This performative dimension, which the written text can document but cannot replicate, is precisely what Jha's essay mourns: the endangered element is not merely the text but the performance event.

## B. Memory, Place, and Endangered Cultural Heritage

Maurice Halbwachs' theory of 'collective memory' (La Mémoire collective, 1950) argues that memory is not an individual psychological phenomenon but a social practice sustained by the community's ongoing engagement with shared places, objects, and rituals. The folk songs Jha documents are precisely this kind of collective memory: the Gosaunik Gīt 'remembers' the household goddess in each performance; the Parātī 'remembers' the devotional dawn practice; the Koṣī Gīta 'remembers' the ecological and mythological character of the Koshi river. When the songs are no longer performed, the collective memories they sustain are not merely forgotten but actively dismembered — the community loses its capacity to access and transmit the cultural knowledge encoded in them.

Edward Casey's phenomenological analysis of place ('Getting Back into Place', 1993) complements Halbwachs: sacred songs are not merely associated with

specific places (the gahbar, the threshold, the dawn household) but constitute those places as meaningful — they make the gahbar a site of divine presence, the dawn a time of spiritual renewal, the Koshi riverbank a place of ecological and mythological significance. When the songs cease, the places themselves lose their cultural and spiritual charge, becoming merely physical locations rather than sites of meaning.

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**A PARALLEL HISTORY OF MAITHILI LITERATURE**

ANNOTATED FOLK SONG ANTHOLOGY

**HRIDAY NARAYAN JHA**

हृदय नारायण झा

*लुप्तप्राय मैथिली लोकगीत — Annotated Bilingual Anthology*

*Indian & Western Literary Theory · Videha Parallel History Framework*

*Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa · Rasa-Dhvani-Vakrokti-Auchitya*

# EDITORIAL INTRODUCTION

This volume presents the complete folk song anthology from Hriday Narayan Jha's essay 'Luptraprāya Maithilī Lokagīta' (Endangered Maithili Folk Songs), first published in Videha Sadeha 1 (January 2009) and archived in Videha Sadeha 30 (pp. 1154–1183). The songs are presented in their original Maithili/Maithili-Braj text, with English translations and critical annotations that situate each song within the Maithili literary tradition, the Tantric-Bhakti devotional context, and the Videha Parallel History Framework.

The anthology presents ten texts: nine devotional songs (Gosaunik Gīta / Bhagavatī Gīta) in nine distinct tunes (as documented by Jha), plus the Jhumra ritual invocation song from Batahū Yādava. The songs are arranged in the order Jha presents them. Each entry includes: the original Maithili/Braj text; an English translation (literary rather than literal); the attribution; and critical annotations covering rasa, dhvani, musical form, and cultural context.

A note on language and script: The songs use a range of registers from Brajabhasha-influenced Maithili (Parātī, traditional songs), through classical

Maithili (Canda Jhā, Vidyapati), to highly Sanskritised devotional Maithili (Madan Upadhyay), to colloquial folk Maithili (Jhumra). This multi-register character is one of the tradition's defining features and is preserved in the original texts.

# I. THE NINE GOSAUNIK GĪTA (गोसाउनिक गीत)

The Gosaunik Gīta (songs of the household deity, gosāunī) are invocations sung at the beginning of any auspicious activity in a Maithili household — a wedding, a birth ceremony, a religious observance, or the inauguration of a new season's work. They are addressed primarily to the Shakti goddess in her forms as Bhavani, Durga, Kali, Tara, and the local village deity. Hriday Narayan Jha documents nine such songs in nine distinct melodic forms (dhuna), ranging from the classical Braj Parātī to original compositions by Vidyapati and Canda Jhā. Each has its own melodic identity, its own ritual context, and its own theological register.

## Song 1: Parātī — Dawn Hymn

Composer: Sahebdas (traditional attribution) | Rāga/Dhuna: Parātī form | Occasion: Dawn awakening ritual, household beginning-of-day

Language: Brajabhasha-Maithili mixed register

**MAITHILI TEXT:**

अजहुँ भजन चित चेत मुगुध मन  अजहु भजन चित चेत ।।

बालापन तरूणापन बीतल , केस भये सभ सेत  मुगुध मन । अजहुँ ।।

जा मुख राम नाम ने आबत , मानहु सो जन प्रेत  मुगुध मन । अजहुँ ।।

हरि विमुखी सुख लहत न कबहुँ , परए नरक के रेत  मुगुध मन । अजहुँ ।।

साहेबदास तोहि क्या लागत , राम नाम मुख लेत  मुगुध मन अजहुँ भजन चित चेत ।।

**ENGLISH TRANSLATION:**

*Even now, O bewildered mind, wake, wake to devotion, even now! || Childhood has passed, youth has passed, all the hair has turned white, O bewildered mind. Even now. || One in whose mouth Ram's name does not come — that person, know, is but a ghost. Even now. || One turned away from Hari never gains joy, falls into the sands of hell. Even now. || What does it cost you, Sahebdas, to take*

*Ram's name on your lips? O bewildered mind, even now, wake, wake to devotion!*

**CRITICAL ANNOTATIONS:**

*Form: Parātī — The Parātī is the archetypal Maithili dawn-song, sung at the boundary between night and day to invoke the divine presence and begin the household's day under spiritual protection. Its performance was traditionally community-wide: sung loudly enough to be heard 'a kosa [about 3 km] away', it served as both a private devotional practice and a public announcement of the dawn.*

*Rasa: The primary rasa is Śānta (tranquillity born of spiritual insight), arrived at through the recognition of wasted time (Karuṇa — pathos). The temporal movement — childhood → youth → white hair → death — is the hetu of the Bhakti argument: 'the time to awaken is always now, because you have already wasted so much time'.*

*Dhvani: The dawn performance context creates a resonant double meaning: the literal 'wake up' (ceta) addressed to the devotee's mind is simultaneous with the actual physical awakening happening as the song is sung at dawn. The bewildered mind (mugudha mana) who does not take Ram's name is the figure who 'sleeps' through the dawn of spiritual opportunity.*

*Navya-Nyāya: The song constructs an anumāna (inference) — from the observed hetu (white hair, age) to the sādhya (urgency of devotional practice) via the vyāpti (those who do not take Ram's name become ghosts after death). This inferential structure gives the song its logical-emotional force.*

## Song 2: Traditional — Durga Invocation (Jhumra form)

Composer: Traditional | Form: Jhumra | Occasion: Gahbar worship, Navratri, communal Durga worship

**MAITHILI TEXT:**

जय वर जय वर दिअ हे गोसाउनि हे मा तारिणी त्रिभुवन देवी ।

सिंह चढल मैया फिरथि गोसाउनि हे मा अतिबल भगवती चण्डी ।।

कट कट कट मैया दन्त शबद कएलि हे मा गट गट गिरलनि काँचे ।

घट घट घट मैया शोणित पिबलनि हे मा मातलि योगिन संगे ।।

**ENGLISH TRANSLATION:**

*Grant us boons, grant us boons, O household goddess, O Mother Deliverer, Deity of the Three Worlds! || Mounted on the lion the Mother roams, O Gosāunī, O Mother, all-powerful Bhagavatī Caṇḍī! || Ka-ka-ka the Mother made the sound of gnashing teeth, O Mother, gulp-gulp she swallowed them raw. || Gulp-gulp-gulp the Mother drank the blood, O Mother, drunk with it, surrounded by yoginīs.*

**CRITICAL ANNOTATIONS:**

*Form: Jhumra — this invocation is in the Jhumra style associated with communal bhagat performance. The onomatopoeic third verse is among the most memorable in Maithili folk poetry.*

*Iconography: The song presents the goddess in her full Tantric iconography: lion-mount (Durgā), skull-crusher (Caṇḍī), blood-drinker with yoginī retinue. This is the fierce (raudra) form of the goddess that the Mithila Shakta tradition celebrates at Navratri.*

*Vakrokti: The onomatopoeic 'kaṭa kaṭa kaṭa' / 'gaṭa gaṭa' / 'ghaṭa ghaṭa ghaṭa' sound-figures are vakrokti at the sonic level: they enact in the body of the singer the visceral reality they describe.*

*Dual rasa: Adbhuta (wonder) and Bhayānaka (terror) coexist — the goddess is simultaneously terrifying and salvific (tāriṇī — deliverer). This is the Tantric paradox that the folk tradition encodes better than most learned treatises.*

## Song 3: Mahāmahopādhyāya Madan Upadhyay — Hymn to Tārā

Composer: Madan Upadhyay (Mahāmahopādhyāya) | Form: Classical Sanskrit-Maithili devotional | Occasion: Tara worship

**MAITHILI TEXT (opening verses):**

जय जय तारिणी भव भय हारिणी दुरित निवारिणी वर माले ।

परम स्वरूपिणी उग्र विभूषिणी दनुज विदूषिणी अहिमाले ।।

पितृवन वासिनि खल खल हासिनि भूत निवासिनि सुविशाले ।

त्रिभुवन तारिणि त्रिपुर विदारिणि वदन करालिनि अहिमाले ।।

**ENGLISH TRANSLATION (opening verses):**

*Victory, victory to Tārā, remover of the fear of worldly existence, remover of sin, O Boon-garlanded One! || Of supreme form, adorned with fierce ornaments, destroyer of demons, O Serpent-garlanded One! || Dwelling in the cremation ground, laughing fiercely, abode of ghosts, O Vast One! || Deliverer of the Three Worlds, destroyer of Tripura, terrible-faced, O Serpent-garlanded One!*

**CRITICAL ANNOTATIONS:**

*The Mahāmahopādhyāya title indicates that Madan Upadhyay was a learned Sanskrit pandit of the highest traditional rank. That his compositions entered the folk devotional tradition alongside anonymous traditional songs is a demonstration of the Maithili tradition's refusal to separate 'learned' and 'popular' religious culture.*

*The cascade of compound epithets — tāriṇī, bhavabhayahāriṇī, duritanivāriṇī, ugravibhūṣiṇī, danujvidūṣiṇī — follows the classical alaṃkāra tradition of multiple-attribute invocation (viśeṣaṇa-mālā), encoding Tāntric theology in the formal structure of Sanskrit praise-poetry.*

## Song 4: Traditional — Bhava-Sāgara Pāra

Composer: Traditional | Form: Bhakti surrender song | Occasion: Communal worship, Gosaunik Gīta

**MAITHILI TEXT:**

करू भव सागर पार हे जननी करू भव सागर पार ।

के मोरा नैया के मोर खेबैया के मोरा उतारत पार हे जननी ।।

अहीं मोर नैया अहीं मोर खेबइया अहीं उतारब पार हे जननी ।।

के मोरा माता पिता मोर के छथि के मोर सहोदर भाई हे जननी ।।

अहीं मोर माता अहीं मोर पिता छी अहीं सहोदर भाई हे जननी ।।

**ENGLISH TRANSLATION:**

*Take me across the ocean of worldly existence, O Mother, take me across! || Who is my boat, who is my boatman, who will take me to the other shore, O Mother? || You are my boat, you are my boatman, you will take me to the other shore, O Mother. || Who is my mother, who is my father, who is my blood-brother, O Mother? || You are my mother, you are my father, you are my blood-brother, O Mother.*

**CRITICAL ANNOTATIONS:**

*The boat metaphor (nāyā / naiyā) for the goddess's salvific power is among the most widely distributed in Indian devotional poetry, from the Alvars to Kabir to Mirabai. Its appearance here in the Maithili folk tradition places Mithila within the pan-Indian current of Bhakti boat-imagery.*

*The theological movement — from question ('Who is my boat?') to answer ('You are my boat') — enacts the devotee's journey from abandonment to discovery of the divine. The repetition of the question-answer structure in verses 2–3 and 4–5 is the folk tradition's characteristic use of incremental repetition to deepen emotional impact.*

*The final equation of the goddess with mother, father, and brother dissolves the conventional family structure in favour of the divine family: the goddess replaces all human relationships as the ultimate source of sustenance and protection. This theological move — familiar from Kabir ('Moko kahān ḍhūṃḍhe re bande') and the Nātha tradition — here appears in specifically Maithili folk form.*

## Songs 5–7: Traditional Invocations — 'He Jagadamba' Series

Three further traditional invocations in the simple folk register, addressed to Jagadamba/Kali/Amba:

**Song 5 (Kālikānta — 'Akhila viśva ke naina tārā'):**

अखिल विश्व के नैन तारा अहीं छी हे जगदम्ब हम्मर सहारा अहीं छी ।।

अनल वायु शशि सूर्य सभ मे अहीं मा , नदी के विमल मंजुधारा अहीं छी ।।

*You are the eye-star of the entire universe, O Jagadamba, you are our support. In fire, wind, moon, sun — you are there, O Mother, you are the pure flowing stream of rivers.*

*Kālikānta's cosmic theology: the goddess is not located in a specific icon but is identified with all the elements of the natural world — fire, wind, moon, sun, river. This is pan-theism in the specifically Mithila devotional mode.*

**Songs 6 & 7 (Traditional — 'He Jagadamba' series):**

हे जगदम्ब जगत माता काली प्रथम प्रणाम करै छी हे ।।

नहि जानी हम पूजा जप तप अटपट गीत गबइ छी हे ।

*O Jagadamba, World-Mother Kali, I offer my first bow to you! || I do not know prayer, I do not know repetition, I do not know austerity — only an incoherent song I sing.*

*The 'incoherent song' (aṭapaṭa gīta) topos: The rhetoric of the devotee's inadequacy ('I do not know') is a characteristic Bhakti move — it creates the devotional paradox in which the acknowledgment of not-knowing is itself the highest form of knowledge (jñāna). The 'aṭapaṭa gīta' is simultaneously the devotee's self-deprecating description of the folk song and the folk song's self-aware assertion of its own value: even the 'incoherent' folk song, offered with sincere devotion, is acceptable to the goddess.*

## Song 8: Mahākavi Vidyapati — 'Ādi bhavānī vinaya tua pāya'

Composer: Vidyapati Ṭhakkuraḥ (c. 1352–1448) | Form: Classical Maithili devotional | Signature: 'Bhanai Vidyapati Kālikeli'

**MAITHILI TEXT:**

आदि भवानी विनय तुअ पाय, तुअ सुमिरइत दुरत दूर जाय ।।

सिंह चढ़ल देवि देल परवेश बघछाल पहिरन जोगिन भेष ।।

बाम लेल खपर दहिन लेल काति, असुर के बधए चललि निशि राति ।।

आदि भवानी विनय तुअ पाय ,तुअ सुमिरइत दुरत दूर जाय ।।

तुअ भल छाज देवि मुण्डहार , नूपूर शबद करए छनकार ।।

भनई विद्यापति कालीकेलि सदा ए रहू मैया दहिन भेलि ।।

**ENGLISH TRANSLATION:**

*O Ādi Bhavānī, I bow at your feet — by remembering you, all sin departs. || Mounted on the lion the Goddess has entered, wearing the tiger-skin, in the form of a yoginī. || In the left hand the skull-cup, in the right the sword, at midnight she goes to slay the demon. || O Ādi Bhavānī... || Well do the severed-head garlands become you, O Goddess — the sound of your anklet-bells jingles and rings. || Vidyapati says: O playful Kali — may you ever be gracious, O Mother.*

**CRITICAL ANNOTATIONS:**

*Vidyapati's signature (bhanai Vidyapati) identifies this as one of his Shakta devotional compositions — a distinct part of his oeuvre from the better-known Krishna-Radha padāvalī. The inclusion of this composition alongside anonymous folk songs in Jha's anthology makes visible the continuity between Vidyapati's classical composition and the living folk tradition.*

*The iconographic precision — skull-cup (left), sword (right), tiger-skin, severed-heads garland, anklet-bells — reflects deep familiarity with Tantric iconographic tradition. Vidyapati was not merely a literary poet but a practitioner within the Mithila Shakta tradition.*

*The phrase 'Kālikeli' (playful Kali) in the signature verse introduces the concept of divine play (līlā) into the Shakta framework — the goddess's fierce acts of demon-slaughter are not mere violence but cosmic play, performed with the ease and delight of divine sport.*

## Song 9: Kaviśvara Canda Jhā — 'Tua binu āja bhavana bhela re'

Composer: Kaviśvara Canda Jhā (1844–1907) | Form: Classical Maithili devotional | Register: Personal-elegiac

**MAITHILI TEXT:**

तुअ बिनु आज भवन भेल रे घन विपिन समान ।।

जनु रिधि सिधिक गरूअ गेल रे मन होइछ भान ।।

परमेश्वरी महिमा तुअ रे जग के नहि जान ।

मोर अपराध छेमब सब रे नहि याचब आन ।।

जगत जननी काँ जग कह रे जन जानकि नाम ।

नहर नेह नियत नित रे रह मिथिला धाम ।।

शुभमयी शुभ शुभ सब दिन रे थिर पति अनुराग ।

तुअ सेवि पूरल मनोरथ रे हम सुलित सभाग ।।

**ENGLISH TRANSLATION:**

*Without you, today the house has become like a dense forest. || It seems the weight of prosperity and powers has lifted — the mind feels bereft. || O Parameśvarī, none in the world knows your glory. || Forgive all my offences — I will ask nothing of another. || Whom the world calls 'Mother of the Universe' — know her name as Jānakī. || Your love flows ever, constant, ever, dwell in the realm of Mithilā. || Auspicious, auspicious, all auspicious be every day — steadfast in devotion to the Husband. || By serving you all desires are fulfilled — I am blessed, I am fortunate.*

**CRITICAL ANNOTATIONS:**

*'Bhavana bhela ghana vipina samāna' — the house becoming like a dense forest in the goddess's absence: this image of civilised domestic space reverting to wild nature is a powerful vakrokti. The forest is the opposite of the home — uncontrolled, dark, inhabited by animals and spirits rather than the family and the divine. Without the goddess's presence, the household loses its civilised character and becomes a wilderness.*

*'Jagan jananī kāṃ jaga kaha re / Jana Jānaki nāma': The identification of the Universal Mother (Jagat Jananī) with Jānakī (Sita, born in Mithila) is a uniquely Mithila theological move. Sita, as daughter of Mithila's king Janaka and as the goddess Earth's daughter, connects the cosmic Mother with the*

*specific sacred geography of Mithila. The goddess is not merely universal — she is specifically the goddess of Mithila, born here, dwelling here ('Mithilā dhāma').*

*Canda Jhā (1844–1907) is best known for his Maithili Rāmāyaṇa, but this devotional composition demonstrates the range of his literary production. The song's formal structure — alternating 're' refrains, four-beat lines — is characteristic of the classical Maithili devotional style.*

## II. THE JHUMRA (झूमरा) — RITUAL INVOCATION SONG

Source: Batahū Yādava (bhagat, practitioner of Jhumra tradition, Mithila). Recorded and transcribed by Hriday Narayan Jha. Published: Videha Sadeha 1 (January 2009). This is, to the best knowledge available from the Videha archive, a unique transcription of a living oral performance.

**CONTEXT NOTE:**

The Jhumra is performed by a nine-member bhagat community, accompanied by the jhāli (cymbal) and māṃḍara (drum). The performance is a ritual of divine possession: during the Jhumra, the lead bhagat's body becomes the vehicle for the goddess's manifestation. The performance takes place in the gahbar (sacred enclosure, typically a temporary structure built of bamboo and palm leaves for Navratri or other goddess worship occasions).

**MAITHILI TEXT:**

अरही जे वन से मइया खरही कटओलियइ हे मइया खरही कटओलियइ हे ।

मइया जी हे बिजुबन कटओलियइ बिट बाँस जगदम्बा रचि रचि महल बनओलियई हे ।।

गोड़लागूँ पैयाँ पडूँ मइया जगदम्बा आइ मइया गहबर अबियउ हे ।

मइया जी हे राखि लिअउ भगत केर लाज जगदम्बा कलजोरि पैयाँ पड़इ छी हे ।।

जहिना बलकबा खेलइ माता के गोदिया हे , भवानी माता के गोदिया हे ।

मइया जी हे तहिना खेलाबहु जग बीच जगदम्बा आब मइया गहबर अबियउ हे ।।

नामो ने जनइ छी मइया पदो ने बूझै छी हे मइया पदो ने बूझै छी हे ।

मइया जी हे सेवक बीच कण्ठ लियउ बास जगदम्बा आब मइया लाज रखियौ हे ।।

गोड़ लागूँ पइयाँ परूँ आद्या जलामुखी हे मइया अद्या जलामुखी हे ।

मइयाजी हे राखि लिअउ अरज केर लाज जगदम्बा सेवक कलजोड़इए हे।।

**ENGLISH TRANSLATION:**

*From the arhar [pigeonpea] forest, O Mother, she cut the stubble-grass, O Mother, she cut the stubble-grass! || O Mother, she cut the lightning-struck forest, with bamboo stalks, O Jagadamba, she built and built a palace! || I bow at your feet, I prostrate myself, O Jagadamba, come, O Mother, come to the gahbar! || O Mother, protect the honour of the bhagat, O Jagadamba, with folded hands I prostrate myself! || As the child plays in the mother's lap, O Mother Bhavani's lap — || O Mother, so play among the world, O Jagadamba, come now, O Mother, come to the gahbar! || I do not know your name, O Mother, I do not know your praises, O Mother! || O Mother, among your servants take up your dwelling in the throat [= grant me the ability to sing], O Jagadamba, now, O Mother, protect my honour! || I bow, I prostrate at your feet, O Ādyā Jvālāmukhī, O Mother Ādyā Jvālāmukhī! || O Mother, protect the honour of this prayer, O Jagadamba, your servant folds his hands before you!*

**CRITICAL ANNOTATIONS:**

*Ecological theology: The palace built from arhar-forest stubble-grass, lightning-struck timber, and bamboo is the folk tradition's most distinctive theological image — the goddess as resident of and builder within the specific Mithila landscape. This is not the Puranic heaven or the Tantric cremation ground but the agricultural universe of the Mithila farmer.*

*The gahbar (गहबर): The gahbar is the sacred enclosure built for the goddess's worship — typically of bamboo and palm leaves, structurally echoing the goddess's palace described in the song. The song's invitation 'āi maikā gahavara abiyau he' (come, O Mother, come to the gahbar) is both the ritual invitation to the goddess and the structural reason for the gahbar's construction.*

*'Kaṇṭha liyau vāsa' (take up your dwelling in the throat): The bhagat's prayer for the goddess to dwell in his throat is a prayer for possession — not merely the ability to sing but the literal embodiment of the divine in the performer's voice. This makes the Jhumra performance a ritual of divine embodiment, not merely musical entertainment.*

*Named bearer: Batahū Yādava. The naming of the practitioner from whom this song was received is unusual in folk song documentation and is characteristic of Jha's scholarly-ethical commitment to acknowledging the community*

*bearers of the tradition rather than treating the song as an anonymous 'folk' artefact.*

*Dhvani: The song's central dhvani is the paradox of the divine's simultaneous transcendence and immanence: the goddess who constructs a palace from forest materials is also the Ādyā Jvālāmukhī (the Primal Flame-Face) — infinite cosmic power dwelling in the bamboo grove. This is the living theological heart of Mithila's Shakta tradition.*

## III. GLOSSARY OF MAITHILI FOLK SONG GENRES

The following glossary provides brief definitions of the nineteen folk song genres identified as endangered by Hriday Narayan Jha in his essay 'Luptraprāya Maithilī Lokagīta':

पराती (Parātī): Dawn hymns, sung at sunrise to begin the household day under divine protection. Pan-Indian tradition with distinct Maithili form.

गोसाउनिक गीत / भगवती गीत (Gosaunik Gīt / Bhagavatī Gīt): Songs addressing the household deity (gosāunī) or the Shakti goddess Bhagavatī. Sung at the beginning of all auspicious activities.

झूमरा (Jhūmarā): Ritual invocation songs for the Bhagavatī, performed by a nine-member bhagat community with drum and cymbal. Associated with divine possession.

सोहर (Sohara): Birth songs, sung to celebrate and sanctify the birth of a child. One of the most widespread life-cycle song genres.

खेलउना (Khelauna): Children's play songs, accompanying children's games and socialisation.

कुमार (Kumāra): Youth initiation songs, marking the transition from childhood to youth.

परिछन (Parichana): Threshold welcoming songs, sung as the bride enters her new home at the threshold ceremony.

चुमान (Cumāna): Ceremonial touching songs, accompanying the ritual touching of the bride's or infant's forehead at auspicious ceremonies.

डहकन (Ḍahakana): Lamentation songs, sung at times of mourning or separation.

विषहारा गीत (Viṣahārā Gīt): Songs addressed to the snake-goddess Viṣahārī/Manasā, invoking protection from snakebite during the monsoon.

झूमरि (Jhūmarī): A lighter variant of the Jhūmarā, associated with women's communal singing.

बटगमनी (Baṭagamanī): Wayfarer songs, associated with journeys and departures.

मलार (Malāra): Monsoon-onset melodies, associated with the arrival of the rains. Corresponds to the classical Malhāra rāga.

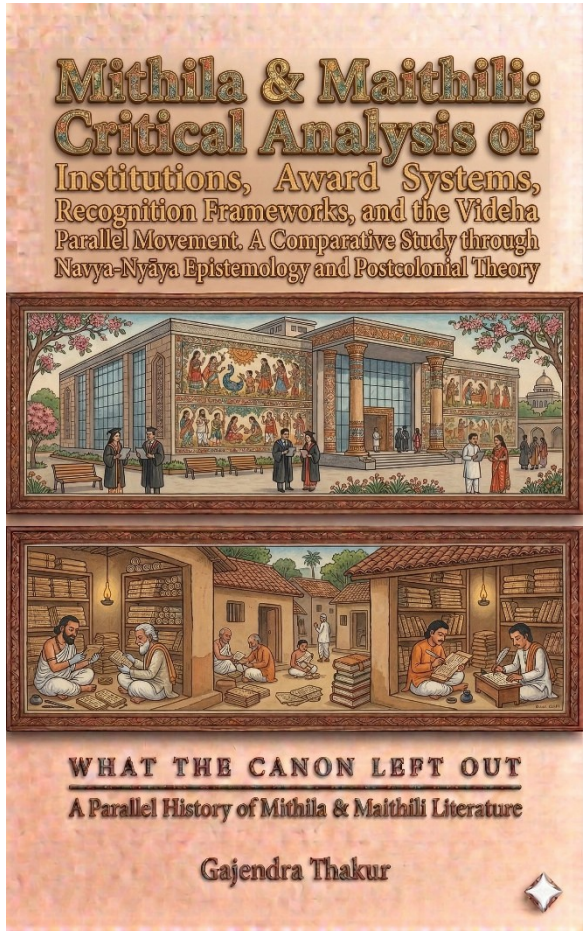
चैमासा (Caimāsā): Four-month monsoon cycle songs, covering the agricultural period from āṣāḍha through āśvina.

लगनी (Laganī): Wedding processional songs, accompanying the wedding procession (barāt) and the related auspicious ceremonies.

समदाउन (Samadāuna): Farewell lament songs, sung at the departure of the married daughter from her parents' home.

कोशी गीत (Koṣī Gīt): Songs of the Koshi river culture, specific to the ecology, mythology, and communities of the Koshi river basin in Mithila.

**LESSON 028 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**




# Mithila & Maithili: Critical Analysis of Institutions

Award Systems, Recognition Frameworks, and the

**Videha Parallel Movement**

*A Comparative Study through Navya-Nyāya Epistemology and Postcolonial Theory*

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## I. Introduction and Theoretical Framework

The literary award ecosystem for Maithili — one of the twenty-two languages of the Eighth Schedule of the Indian Constitution and a language with a written literary tradition predating most European vernaculars — operates across at least four distinct institutional layers: the Indian national cultural bodies (Sahitya Akademi, Lalit Kala Akademi, Sangeet Natak Akademi), Nepal's cultural institutions (Nepal Pragya Pratishthan and associated prizes), regional civil society awards, and the counter-canonical Videha Samman instituted by the Videha eJournal (ISSN 2229-547X, since 2000) as a deliberate parallel to each of the above.

This critical analysis proceeds from three methodological commitments. First, a performance evaluation framework asks whether each institution has fulfilled its stated mandate vis-à-vis Maithili, measuring outputs against declared objectives. Second, a comparative analysis situates each body within the broader pan-Indian and South Asian literary awards landscape. Third, and most distinctively, Navya-Nyāya epistemology — developed by the fourteenth-century Mithilā philosopher Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya in his Tattvacintāmaṇi — provides an analytical grammar: the categories of pramāṇa (valid cognition), vyāpti (invariable concomitance), and pakṣatā (property of the subject) are deployed to interrogate the validity of institutional claims to representativeness, literary authority, and cultural legitimacy.

The Videha Parallel Literature Movement, as articulated in the Videha eJournal across its 408+ issues, frames the mainstream institutions as embodying what it calls a 'Sahitya Akademi canon' — a hegemonic, upper-caste, Darbhanga-centred conception of Maithili literary excellence that systematically excludes subaltern, Dalit, women's, and democratic traditions. The parallel award system is not mere mimicry but epistemological counter-proposal: it asserts different criteria of pramāṇa for literary value.

# II. Sahitya Akademi: Institutional History and the Seven Award Categories for Maithili

## 2.1 Institutional Overview

The Sahitya Akademi, established on 12 March 1954 and headquartered at Rabindra Bhavan near Mandi House, New Delhi, is India's National Academy of Letters. It is autonomous but government-funded, operating under the Department of Culture. Its recognition of Maithili as an official literary language predates the language's constitutional recognition: the Sahitya Akademi began giving the main award for Maithili in 1966, while Maithili was added to the Eighth Schedule only in 2003 (via the 92nd Constitutional Amendment).

The Akademi currently administers seven categories of recognition relevant to Maithili and the other 23 recognized languages. Each represents a distinct institutional theory of literary value.

VIDEHA SAMMAN VIA SPECIAL ISSUES:

For about five to six months, Videha has been inviting suggestions from its readers. From the suggestions received, Videha selects only living authors. Similarly, the institutions involved must also be currently active.

**For the "Nit Naval" (Ever-New) Series:** A question may arise: is the above rule such that all deserving living authors will eventually be selected in a timely manner? The answer is no. Videha has its own limitations, and Videha’s readers have theirs as well. However, within these limits, we must give our best efforts and pave a way for Maithili such that the literature of the next 500–600 years finds inspiration from the path set by Videha. With this vision, Videha is also focusing its attention on those deserving living authors for whom a special issue of Videha could not be published for some reason. This is named the Videha **"Nit Naval Series."**

The main points of this new concept are as follows:

1. The editor of Videha, Gajendra Thakur, will write a focused critique on a living author or artist, covering their entire available body of work. The language of this book will be either Maithili or English. The first edition of this book will be

released as an e-book, and efforts will be made to bring out a print version as well, depending on the circumstances.

2. The selection of the author or artist will be made by the editor based on his own interest or the interests of the Videha team.
3. Selection will be possible only for those authors or artists whose complete available works have been made public in PDF format through Videha. For artists, YouTube and other sites will also be considered valid sources.
4. Work on the selected author or artist for this project will be conducted according to the editor's schedule; therefore, it is not possible to specify a fixed timeframe.

## 2.2 The Seven Award Categories — Maithili Performance

| Award Category | Established | Prize (₹) | Maithili First Award | Recent Maithili Winner |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Sahitya Akademi Fellowship (Fellow) | 1968 | Lifetime + Plaque | Chandra Nath Mishra Amar for Maithili, Nagarjun (Yatri) for Hindi-Maithili | — (Critical gap) |
| Bhasha Samman | 1996 | ₹1,00,000 | Maithili scholars included | Periodic |
| Tagore Sahitya Puraskar | 2012 | ₹1,00,000 | Jagdish Prasad Mandal | Sahitya Akademi discontinued this award |
| Main Sahitya Akademi | 1966 (Maithili) | ₹1,00,000 | Yashodhar Jha (1966) | Mahendra (2025) |

| Award | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Bal Sahitya Puraskar | 2010 | ₹50,000 | Given annually | Active |
| Yuva Puraskar (Young Literateur) | 2011 | ₹50,000 | Given annually | Active |
| Translation Prize | 1990 | ₹50,000 | Upendranath Jha ‘Vyas’ | Active |

## 2.3 The Main Sahitya Akademi Award for Maithili — Historical Critical Evaluation

Since its inception in 1966, the Sahitya Akademi Award for Maithili has been conferred every year except 1967, 1972 and 1974

**MAITHILI (Since 1966)**

| YEAR | BOOK | AUTHOR |
|---|---|---|
| 2025 | Dhatri Paat San Gaam (Memoir) | Mahendra |
| 2024 | Prabandh Sangrah (Essays) | Mahendra Malangia |
| 2023 | Bodha Sanketan (Essays) | Basukinath Jha |
| 2022 | Pen-Drive Me Prithvi (Poetry) | Ajit Azad |
| 2021 | Pangu (Novel) | Jagdish Prasad Mandal |
| 2020 | Gachh Roosal Achhi (Short Stories) | Kamalkant Jha |
| 2019 | Jingik Oriaon Karait (Poetry) | Kumar Manish Arvind |
| 2018 | Parineeta (Short Stories) | Bina Thakur |
| 2017 | Jahalak Diary (Poetry) | Udaya Narayana Singh ‘Nachiketa’ |
| 2016 | Barki Kaki at Hotmail Dot Corn (Short Stories) | Shyam Darihare |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 2015 | Khissa (Short Stories) | Man Mohan Jha |
| 2014 | Uchat (Novel) | Asha Mishra |
| 2013 | Sangharsh Aa Sehanta (Memoirs) | Sureshwar Jha |
| 2012 | Kist-Kist Jeewan (Autobiography) | Shefalika Verma |
| 2011 | Apaksha (Poetry) | Uday Chandra Jha 'Vinod' |
| 2010 | Bhamati (Novel) | Usha Kiran Khan |
| 2009 | Ganga-Putra (Short Stories) | Man Mohan Jha |
| 2008 | Katek Daaripar (Memoirs) | Mantreshwar Jha |
| 2007 | Sarokar (Short Stories) | Pradip Bihari |
| 2006 | Kaath (Short Stories) | Bibhuti Anand |
| 2005 | Chanan Ghan Gachchiya (Poetry) | Vivekanand Thakur |
| 2004 | Shakuntala (Epic) | Chandrabhanu Singh |
| 2003 | Ritambhara (Short Stories) | Niraja Renu (Khamakhy A Devi) |
| 2002 | Sahasmukhi Chowk Par (Poems) | Somdev |
| 2001 | Pratijna Pandav (Epic) | Babuajee Jha 'Ajnat' |
| 2000 | Katek Raas Baat (Poetry) | Ramanand Renu |
| 1999 | Gananayak (Short Stories) | Saketanand |
| 1998 | Takait Achhi Chirai (Poetry) | Jeeva Kant |
| 1997 | Dhwast Hoet Shanti Stoop (Poetry) | Keerti Narayan Mishra |
| 1996 | Aai Kaalhi Parsoo (Short stories) | Raj Mohan Jha |
| 1995 | Kavita Kusumanjali (Poetry) | Jayamanta Mishra |
| 1994 | Uchitavakta (Short stories) | Gangesh Gunjan |
| 1993 | Samak Pauti (Short stories) | Govinda Jha |
| 1992 | Vividha (Essays) | Bhimanath Jha |
| 1991 | Pasijhaita Pathar (Play) | Ramdeo Jha |
| 1990 | Prabhasak Katha (Short stories) | Prabhas Kumar Choudhuri |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 1989 | Parasar (Epic) | Kanchinath Jha ‘Kiran’ |
| 1988 | Mantraputra (Novel) | Mayanand Mishra |
| 1987 | Atita (Short stories) | Umanath Jha |
| 1986 | Natik Patrak Uttar (Belles-lettres) | Subhadra Jha |
| 1985 | Jeevan Yatra (Autobiography) | Hari Mohan Jha |
| 1984 | Suryamukhi (Poetry) | Arsi Prasad Singh |
| 1983 | Maithili Patrakaritaka Ithihas (Treatise) | Chandranath Mishra ‘Amar’ |
| 1982 | Marichika (Novel) | Lily Ray |
| 1981 | Agastyayaini (Epic) | Markandeya Pravasi |
| 1980 | Ee Bataha Sansar (Novel) | Sudhanshu Shekhar Chaudhary |
| 1979 | Krishna-charit (Poetry) | Tantranath Jha |
| 1978 | Baji Uthal Murali (Poetry) | Upendra Thakur ‘Mohan’ |
| 1977 | Avahatta: Udbhava O Vikas (Literary criticism) | Rajeshwar Jha |
| 1976 | Sitayana (Epic) | Vaidyanath Mallik ‘Vidhu’ |
| 1975 | Kichhu Dekhal Kichhu Sunal (Reminiscences) | Girindramohan Mishra |
| 1973 | Naika Banijara (Novel) | Braj Kishore Verma ‘Manipadma’ |
| 1971 | Payasvini (Poetry) | Surenda Jha ‘Suman’ |
| 1970 | Radha Viraha (Epic poetry) | Kashikant Mishra ‘Madhup’ |
| 1969 | Du Patra (Novel) | Upendranth Jha |
| 1968 | Patrahin Nagna Gachh (Poetry) | ‘Yatri’ (Vaidyanath Mishra) |
| 1966 | Mithila-Baibhav (Philosophical treatise) | Yashodhar Jha |

(No Awards in 1967, 1972 and 1974)

**The Repeat Award Problem: Ramdeo Jha got Main Award, Translation Prize as well as Bal Sahitya Award from Sahitya Akademi.**

A pattern analysis of the 57 awardees reveals: (a) Brahmins won the award 48 times; (b) Poetry and fiction dominate over criticism and drama; (c) Women have received the award only 6 times out of which five are Brahmins and one Kayastha, (d) No Dalit has ever received the award, ( e)only one OBC Sh Jagdish Prasad Mandal received the award (f) even among upper castes only three awardees are Rajputs and five awardees are kayasthas; (e) The Darbhanga-Madhubani geographic cluster produced a plurality of winners.

From a Navya-Nyāya epistemological standpoint, the selection system exhibits what Gaṅgeśa would identify as an anuvyāpti (too-narrow invariable concomitance): the institutional criteria for 'literary merit' (vyāpti: literary excellence = recognition by committee) are calibrated to a narrow tradition, producing a systemic bias that is not random error but structural misrepresentation (hetvābhāsa: fallacious reason).

BAL SAHITYA PURASKAR

| **MAITHILI** | | |
|---|---|---|
| 2025 | Chukka (Short Stories) | Munni Kamat |
| 2024 | Anar (Short Stories) | Narayanjee |
| 2023 | Ol Katra, Jhol Katra (Poetry) | Akshay Anand 'Sunny' |
| 2022 | Uran Chhoo (Short Stories) | Virendra Jha |
| 2021 | Lagi Jo Phool Akash (Poetry) | Anmol Jha |
| 2020 | Sonahula Ijotwala Khidki (Poetry) | Siya Ram Jha 'Saras' |
| 2019 | Ee Phoolak Guldasta (Stories) | Rishi Bashistha |
| 2018 | Khissa Sunu Bau (Short Stories) | Vaidya Nath Jha |
| 2017 | Lalgachhi (Novel) | Amlendu Sekhar Pathak |
| 2016 | Bharat Bhagya Vidhata (Part-I) (Biography) | Prem Mohan Mishra |
| 2015 | Hansani Pan A Bajanta Supari (Novel) | Ramdeo Jha |
| 2014 | Hamar Athanni Khaslai Van Me (Poetry) | (Late) Jeevakant |
| 2013 | Hamra Beech Vigyan (Essays) | Dhirendra Kumar Jha |
| 2012 | Pilpilha Gachha (Short Stories) | Muralidhar Jha |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 2011 | Jakar Nari Chatur Hoi (Short Stories) | Mayanath Jha |
| 2010 | Ee Bhetal Tan Ki Bhetal (Short Stories) | Tara Nand Viyogee |

YUVA PURASKAR

| **MAITHILI** | | |
|---|---|---|
| 2025 | Banaras Aa Hum (Poetry) | Neha Jha Mani |
| 2024 | Nadi Ghati Sabhyata (Poetry) | Rinki Jha Rishika |
| 2023 | Kahbak Achhi Hamra (Poetry) | Sanskriti Mishra |
| 2022 | Khurchanbhaik Kachhmachchhi (Satire) | Navkrishna Aihik |
| 2021 | Anshu Bani Pasari Jaeb (Poetry) | Amit Mishra |
| 2020 | Gassa (Short Stories) | Sonu Kuma Jha |
| 2019 | Raag-Upraag (Poetry) | Amit Pathak |
| 2018 | Varnit Rasa (Poetry) | Umesh Paswan |
| 2017 | Dhartis Akash Dhari (Poetry) | Chandan Kumar Jha |
| 2016 | Je Kahi Nahi Saklahun (Poetry) | Deep Narayan 'Vidyarthi' |
| 2015 | Pratiwadi Ham (Poetry) | Narayan Jha |
| 2014 | Visdanti Varmal Kalak Rati (Poetry) | Praveen Kashyap |
| 2013 | Ankura Rahal Sangharsh (Poetry) | Dilip Kumar Jha 'Lootan' |
| 2012 | Etbe Taa Naih (Poetry) | Arunabh Saurabh |
| 2011 | Hathat Parivartan (Play) | Anand Kumar Jha |
| **MALAYALAM** | | |

2.4 Bhasha Samman — Critical Assessment

The Bhasha Samman, instituted in 1996, recognizes contributions to the development of languages not included in the main award (including oral traditions, classical languages, Maithili in its pre-Eighth Schedule phase). While Maithili scholars have received Bhasha Sammans, the selection process remains opaque. The award has valued lexicographic, editorial, and archival work but has undervalued digital and web-based contributions — a critical failure in an era when journals like Videha (since 2000) represent the primary infrastructure for living Maithili literature.

Udaynath Jha ‘Ashok’ who alongwith Ramanath Jha is responsible for honour killing of Gangesa Upadhyaya got this Bhasha Samman.

## 2.5 The Fellowship (Sahitya Akademi Fellow) — The Most Critical Gap

The Sahitya Akademi Fellowship is the highest literary honour the Akademi bestows, reserved for 'immortals of literature.' As of 2025, only Chandra Nath Mishra Amar for Maithili & Nagarjun (Yatri) for Hindi & Maithili have been elected Fellow. This is an extraordinary institutional failure. Maithili possesses one of the oldest continuous literary traditions in the subcontinent, tracing from Pre-Jyotirishwar Vidyapati [different from Vidyapati (c. 1352–1448)], arguably the most significant medieval Indian poet outside the Sanskrit tradition. The absence of any Maithili Fellow — while languages with far shorter literary histories have produced Fellows — is a prima facie case of institutional discrimination that cannot be explained by any neutral criterion.

Videha's parallel system responds to this gap directly: the Videha Samantarar Sahitya Akademi Fellow Puraskar was the very first category of the Videha Samman, awarded in 2010 to Govind Jha and in 2011 to Ramanand Renu — two scholars whose lifetime contributions were institutionally unrecognized by the mainstream.

## 2.6 Tagore Sahitya Puraskar — Asymmetric Access

The Tagore Sahitya Puraskar, carrying a prize of ₹1 lakhs (the highest cash award in Indian literary recognition), was instituted in 2013 and is given to outstanding works of literature. It was given to Jagdish Prasad Mandal. The Tagore Prize's selection mechanism — dependent on publisher submissions and institutional networks in which Maithili publishing remains marginalized — structurally disadvantages the language. This award has been discontinued by the Sahitya Akademi.2.7 Bal Sahitya Puraskar and Yuva Puraskar

Both prizes have been awarded to Maithili writers consistently since their inception (2010 and 2011 respectively). They represent the most democratic tier of Sahitya Akademi recognition, with broader selection processes and smaller prize amounts (₹50,000 each). The Videha parallel system mirrored these categories from the outset, and the parallel awards (as documented in the Videha Samman booklet, 2012 edition) have in several cases preceded the Sahitya Akademi recognition of the same authors — suggesting that Videha has functioned as a discovery mechanism for talent that the Akademi subsequently validates.

## 2.8 Translation Prize

The Sahitya Akademi Translation Prize for Maithili has been awarded for both translations into Maithili from other languages and translations from Maithili. Notable recent awards include Rajnand Jha's Maithili rendering of Samaresh Majumdar's Kaalbela (2006). The prize has privileged translation from major Indian languages (Bengali, Hindi) into Maithili, while translation from Maithili into other languages — a crucial vector for Maithili's international recognition — has been relatively neglected.

TRANSLATION PRIZES

**MAITHILI**

| YEAR | TITLE OF THE TRANSLATION | TRANSLATOR | TITLE OF THE ORIGINAL (LANGUAGE/GENRE) | AUTHOR |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 2024 | Aaranyak | Keshkar Thakur | Aaranyak, (Novel), Bengali | Bhibhutibhushan Bandyopadhyaya |
| 2023 | Nilkantha | Menaka Mallik | Nilkantha (Novel), Nepali | Matsyendra Pradhan |
| 2022 | Azaadi | Ratneshwar Mishra | Azadi (Novel), English | Chaman Nahal |
| 2021 | Smarangatha | Late Ms. Shikha Goyal | Smarangatha (Autobiographical Novel), Marathi | G.N. Dandekar |
| 2020 | Chaupadi | (Late) Jitendra Narayan Jha | Chatushpathi (Novel). Bengali. | Swapanmay Chakraborthy |
| 2019 | Akaal Me Saaras | Kedar Kanan | Akaal Mein Saaras (Collection of Poetry), Hindi | Kedarnath Singh |
| 2018 | Herael Jakan Kichhu | Sadare Alam 'Gauhar' | Khoya Huwa Sa Kuchh (Poetry), Urdu | Nida Fazli |
| 2017 | Aangliyat | Indra Kant Jha | Aangliyat (Novel), Gujarati | Joseph Macwan |

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| 2016 | Mithilak Lok Sahityak Bhumika | Rewati Mishra | Introduction To The Folk Literature Of Mithila (Criticism) | Jayakant Mishra |
| 2015 | Badali Jaichh Ghareta | Devendra Jha | Bari Badle Jai (Novel) Bengali | Ramapada Choudhuri |
| 2014 | Malahin | Ram Narayan Singh | Chemmeen (Malayalam) Novel | Thakazhi Shivashanakara Pillai |
| 2013 | Bangla Ekanki Natya Sangraha | Guna Nath Jha | Bangla Ekanki Natya Sangraha (Bengali) Collection of One Act Plays | Comp.& Ed. By Ajit Kumar Ghosh (Various Authors) |
| 2012 | Kermelin | Mahendra Narayan Ram | Karmelin (Konkani) Novel | Damodar Mauzo |
| 2011 | Uparvas Kathatrayee | Khushi Lai Jha | Uparvas Kathatrayee (Gujarati) Novel | Raghuveer Chaudhari |
| 2010 | Prajwalit Pragya | Nityanand Lai Das | Ignited Minds (English) Essays | A.P.J. Abdul Kalam |
| 2009 | Beechhal Berayal Marathi Ekanki | Bhalchandra Jha | Nivdak Marathi Ekankika (Marathi) Plays | Various Authors |
| 2008 | Samrachnavad, Uttar Samrachnavad Evam Tara Kanta Jha Prachya Kavyashastra | Tara Kanta Jha | Sakhtiyat, Pas-Sakhtiyat Aur Mashriqi Sheriyat (Urdu) Criticism | Gopi Chand Narang |
| 2007 | Yuddha Aur Yoddha | Ananta Bihar Lal Das ‘Indu’ | Yudha Ra Yoddha (Nepali) Poetry | Agam Singh Giri |
| 2006 | Kalbela | Rajanada Jha | Kalbela (Bengali) Novel | Samaresh Majumdar |
| 2005 | Biharak Lok Katha | Yogananda Jha | Folk Tales of Bihar (English) Folk Tales | P.C. Roy Choudhary |

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|---|---|---|---|---|
| 2004 | Premchand: Chayanit Katha-I | Prafulla Kumar Singh ‘Maun’ | Collection (Hindi) Short Stories | Premchand |
| 2003 | Manoj Dasak Katha O Kahini | (Late) Upendra Doshi | Manoj Dasank Katha O Kahini (Oriya) Short Stories | Manoj Das |
| 2002 | Patjharak Swar | Prabodh Narayan Singh | Patjhar Ki Awaz (Urdu) Short Stoties | Qurratulain Hyder |
| 2001 | Anatariksha Me Visphot | Sureshwar Jha | Antaralatil Sphot (Marathi) Science Fiction | Jayant V. Narlikar |
| 2000 | Tamas | Amaresh Pathak | Tamas (Hindi) Novel | Bhisham Sahni |
| 1999 | Arogya Niketan | Murari Madhusudan Thakur | Arogya Niketan (Bengali) Novel | Tarashankar Bandyopadhyay |
| 1998 | Parashuramak Beechal-Bereyal Katha | Chandnath Mishra ‘Amar’ | Selection (Bengali) Short stories | Rajsekhar Basu (Parashuram) |
| 1997 | Matimangal | Navin Choudhary | Marali Mannige (Kannada) Novel | K. Shivarama Karanth |
| 1996 | Abul Kalam Azad | Fazlur Rahman Hashmi | Abul Kalam Azad (Urdu) Autobiography | Abul Kalam Azad |
| 1995 | Rabindra Natakavali Vol. I | Surendra Jha ‘Suman’ | Chirakumar Sabha, Visarjan and Chitrangada (Bengali) Plays | Rabindranath Tagore |
| 1994 | Sagai | Ramdeo Jha | Ek Chader Maili Si (Urdu) Novel | Rajinder Singh Bedi |
| 1993 | Nepali Sahityak Itihas | Govind Jha | History of Nepali Literature (English) | Kumar Pradhan |
| 1991 | Saratchandra: Vyakti Evam | Shailendra Mohan Jha | Saratchandra: | Subodh Chandra |

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|---|---|---|---|---|
| | Kalakar | Man and Artist (English) Criticism | | Sengupta |
| 1990 | Vipradas | Upendranath Jha ‘Vyas’ | Vipradas (Bengali) Novel | Saratchandra Chattopadhyay |

**The translation prizes were given to persons who undertook no translation other than on which they received the award and that so on assignments received from Sahitya Akademi.**

## III. Critical Analysis of the Seven Recognized Literary Associations

As per the Sahitya Akademi's List of Literary Associations (May 2022), seven organizations are recognized for Maithili:

### 3.1 Akhil Bharatiya Maithili Sahitya Parishad (ABMSP), Darbhanga

Founded in Darbhanga (Bihar), the ABMSP is the oldest and most politically influential organization in the Maithili literary establishment. It has historically been identified with the upper-caste (chiefly Brahmin/Maithil Brahmin) Maithili literary tradition and served as the primary feeder institution for Sahitya Akademi nominations. Its recognition as the premier literary association has given it disproportionate influence over the canon. However, its activity record post-2000 shows a declining trajectory in publications, events, and new talent development. The ABMSP's association with the Darbhanga Raj patronage culture has made it conservative in admitting experimental, Dalit, or women-centred writing into its remit.

Critically, the ABMSP's geographic location in Darbhanga increasingly disconnects it from the majority of the Maithili-speaking population, which has migrated to Delhi, Kolkata, Mumbai, and the Gulf states. A literary association rooted in one district cannot claim to represent a pan-Maithili cultural constituency.

### 3.2 Chetna Samiti, Patna (Vidyapati Bhavan)

Chetna Samiti, operating from Vidyapati Bhavan in Patna, occupies a pivotal position: it is located in the state capital, giving it political access. It has been

associated with organizing the annual Vidyapati Puja and maintaining the Vidyapati cultural calendar. However, the organization's conflation of literary activity with religious/ceremonial observance around Vidyapati risks freezing Maithili literary identity in a medieval frame, impeding recognition of modern and contemporary literary production.

The organization has been reasonably active in promoting Maithili in Bihar government circles and has played a role in advocating for Maithili's Eighth Schedule recognition. However, its literary output — publications, translations, criticism — remains thin compared to its institutional footprint.

### 3.3 Mithila Sanskritik Parishad, Kolkata

Representing the Maithili diaspora in West Bengal, the Mithila Sanskritik Parishad occupies an important but undervalued position. Kolkata's historical role as a centre of Maithili intellectual activity (from the Bengal Renaissance period onward, and through figures like Chandranath Mishra 'Amar') has not been adequately reflected in Sahitya Akademi institutional arrangements. The Parishad's activities have focused on cultural events and local community maintenance rather than systematic literary criticism or publication.

### 3.4 Vidyapati Seva Sansthan, Darbhanga (Mithila Bhavan Parisar)

The Vidyapati Seva Sansthan is the fourth recognized body, sharing Darbhanga geography with the ABMSP and reinforcing the geographic concentration problem. While its devotion to Vidyapati's legacy has value, the duplication of organizational mission between two Darbhanga-based entities in the recognized list represents an institutional inefficiency. Neither organization has published a comprehensive critical edition of Vidyapati's works in the digital era.

**5. Anand Samajik Sanskritik Sahityik Manch (Darbhanga)**

**6. Mithila Sanskritik Parishad (Jamshedpur)**

**7. Akhil Bharatiya Mithila Sangh (New Delhi)**

### 3.5 Critical Synthesis: The Recognition Problem

The seven recognized associations share a common limitation: they are legacy institutions of the mid-twentieth century that have not adapted to the digital, diaspora, and democratic realities of twenty-first century Maithili literary life.

None has a functioning website with current content; none publishes a peer-reviewed journal; none has a documented system for discovering and supporting young authors that is commensurate with Videha's output.

Navya-Nyāya analysis: The recognition of these seven bodies as the authoritative mediating institutions between Maithili literature and the Sahitya Akademi creates an anupalabdhi (non-perception) problem — the absence of organizations representing subaltern, digital, and diasporic Maithili becomes epistemically invisible within the institutional framework.

## IV. Lalit Kala Akademi and Maithili/Mithila Visual Arts

The Lalit Kala Akademi (National Academy of Art), headquartered in New Delhi (lalitkala.gov.in), was established in 1954 alongside the Sahitya Akademi. Its mandate covers visual arts — painting, sculpture, printmaking, photography.

### 4.1 Mithila Painting: A Case of Recognition Without Institutionalization

Mithila (Madhubani) painting is internationally one of India's most recognized folk art traditions, having gained global recognition through UNESCO listings, New York Museum exhibitions, and commercial markets. The Lalit Kala Akademi has recognized individual Mithila painters — Sita Devi, Ganga Devi, Yamuna Devi received National Awards — but the institutional engagement with Mithila art reveals a fundamental tension: the Academy's recognition apparatus favours individual 'masters' over the collective, intergenerational, and predominantly women-created tradition that Mithila painting represents.

The critical problem is that Lalit Kala Akademi recognition has simultaneously preserved and commodified Mithila art, while failing to protect the intellectual property of individual Mithila artists against commercial reproduction. The Academy has no dedicated centre in the Mithila region; artists must travel to Delhi to participate in officially recognized exhibitions.

### 4.2 Videha Parallel: Samantarar Lalit Kala Akademi Samman

Videha's parallel Lalit Kala Akademi equivalent — the Videha Samantarar Lalit Kala Akademi Samman — has addressed this gap by recognizing not only painters but also sculptors, craftspersons, and performing artists. Crucially, the

Videha Samman has included chitrakar (Mithila painters), shilpi (craftspersons), and folk instrument musicians — categories entirely outside the Lalit Kala Akademi's recognition frame. As documented in the Videha Samman booklet, the 2012 awards included: Panaklal Mandal and Ramesh Kumar Bharati (Mithila painting); Jagdish Mallik (shilpi-vastukalā); Yadunandan Pandit (mūrti-mritkā kalā); and Jhemeli Mukhiya (kāṣṭha-kalā — woodcraft).

This is a significant epistemological intervention: it insists that the visual arts of Mithila cannot be adequately captured by the fine arts/folk arts binary that structures the Lalit Kala Akademi's recognition system.

## V. Sangeet Natak Akademi and Maithili Performing Arts

The Sangeet Natak Akademi (National Academy of Music, Dance and Drama), headquartered in New Delhi (sangeetnatak.gov.in), was established in 1952. It administers Fellowships (Ratna Sadasya), Awards (annual), and the Sangeet Natak Akademi Amrit Award.

### 5.1 Institutional Engagement with Maithili Performing Arts

Maithili possesses extraordinarily rich performing arts traditions: Bidesia and Natua dance forms, the Sama-Chakeva festival traditions, Jhijhia and Jitiya folk performances, the Maithili theatre tradition, and classical/semi-classical vocal traditions associated with Vidyapati's padavali. The Sangeet Natak Akademi has recognized individual performers in these traditions but has not created any dedicated institutional infrastructure for research, training, or preservation specific to the Mithila performing arts complex.

No Maithili artist has received the Sangeet Natak Akademi Fellowship (the highest honour) as of the preparation of this report — a gap as striking as the absence of a Maithili Sahitya Akademi Fellow, given the antiquity and richness of the Maithili performing arts tradition.

### 5.2 The Videha Natya Utsav as Parallel Archive

The Videha Maithili Natya Utsav, (ISBN 978-93-80538-66-2, 2012), represents the most systematic attempt to document and critically evaluate the Maithili parallel theatre movement. Edited by Gajendra Thakur with drama editor Bechan Thakur, this publication compiled performing arts activity from Videha

Issues 51-100 and provided a critical analysis of caste-based theatre (jātigrast rangmanch) versus democratic Maithili theatre.

The Videha Samman for performing arts recognized, in its earliest iterations: Parmanand Thakur (harmonium), Bulan Raut (dholak), Bahadur Ram (rasnachowki player), and Hari Narayan Mandal (nritya/dance) — folk musicians and performers who would never appear on a Sangeet Natak Akademi shortlist but who represent the living substrate of Maithili performing arts.

## VI. Nepal's Literary Award Ecosystem for Maithili

Maithili is the second most widely spoken language in Nepal, with significant populations in the Terai (Madhesh) region. Nepal's literary institutions have approached Maithili with a complex combination of recognition and administrative neglect.

### 6.1 Nepal Pragya Pratishthan (Nepal Academy)

Nepal Pragya Pratishthan (nepalacademy.gov.np), Nepal's national academy, was established in 1957 BS (1976 CE). Membership (sadasya) in the Pratishthan constitutes the highest literary recognition in Nepal, analogous to the Sahitya Akademi Fellowship. The Academy administers the Prithvi Pragya Puraskar (given every five years), the Tribhuvan Pragya Puraskar (every three years), and the Mahendra Pragya Puraskar for contributions to language, literature, and culture.

Critically, Maithili representation in the Nepal Pragya Pratishthan has historically been minimal, despite Maithili's demographic significance in Nepal. The Academy has been dominated by Khas-Nepali cultural interests, and Madheshi/Terai languages including Maithili have been systematically underrepresented in both membership and award categories.

### 6.2 Vidyapati Puraskar

The Vidyapati Puraskar is Nepal's most prestigious literary award specifically connected to Maithili cultural heritage, named for the great poet Vidyapati whose connections to the Nepal Terai are historically documented. However, the award has primarily been used to recognize Nepali-medium works by Terai

authors, rather than Maithili-language literature per se — a conceptual confusion that has diluted its cultural significance.

## 6.3 Kosh Puraskar

The Kosh Puraskar recognizes contributions to Nepali lexicography. While this primarily concerns Nepali-language scholarship, it has occasionally recognized multilingual scholarship touching on Maithili — especially relevant given the shared literary heritage of Mithila-Terai scholarship.

## 6.4 Phulkumari Mahato Memorial Trust, Kathmandu

This award, administered by the Phulkumari Mahato Memorial Trust, is specifically dedicated to Maithili literature in Nepal and has been one of the most consistent institutional recognizers of Maithili literary production in the Terai. It represents civil-society patronage that has filled a gap left by both the Nepal Pragya Pratishthan and the Indian Sahitya Akademi.

## 6.5 Sajha Puraskar

The Sajha Puraskar, established in 2026 BS (c. 1969 CE) by Sajha Publications, is given to the best-selling book published by Sajha. While primarily a Nepali-language prize, it represents the commercial dimension of literary recognition — a dimension largely absent from both Indian and Nepali national award systems for Maithili.

## 6.6 Critical Assessment: Nepal's Institutional Failure

Nepal's literary institutions collectively represent a missed opportunity. Given Maithili's constitutional recognition as one of Nepal's national languages (under the 2015 Constitution, Maithili is listed as a national language in Schedule 1), the absence of commensurate institutional support from Nepal's national academy is a significant failure of the democratic cultural project. The Nepal Pragya Pratishthan's membership structure, which privileges Kathmandu-based scholars in the Khas-Nepali tradition, has not been restructured to reflect Nepal's post-2015 federal and multicultural constitutional commitments.

# VII. Videha Samman: Architecture and Philosophy of the Parallel System

## 7.1 Institutional Genesis

The Videha Samman was inaugurated in 2010-11 as an explicit counter-institution to the mainstream award ecosystem. Its formal description — 'Samantarar Sahitya Akademi Puraskar, Samantarar Lalit Kala Akademi Puraskar, Samantarar Sangeet-Natak Akademi Puraskar' — announces its parallel and critical relationship to the three national bodies. The name 'samantarar' (parallel) is not coincidental: it invokes the mathematical structure of parallel lines that never intersect, suggesting a permanent structural critique rather than a temporary oppositional stance.

## 7.2 Award Categories and Their Philosophy

The Videha Samman operates across three domains mirroring the three national bodies:

Samantarar Sahitya Akademi Samman covers: (1) Fellow (lifetime achievement), (2) Main literary award (best original work), (3) Children's literature (bal sahitya), (4) Young writer award (yuva puraskar), (5) Translation award (anuvad puraskar), and (6) Bhasha Samman (language promotion). This structure is isomorphic to the Sahitya Akademi system, enabling point-by-point comparison.

Samantarar Lalit Kala Akademi Samman covers: Mithila painting (chitrakalā), sculpture (mūrtikalā), woodcraft (kāṣṭha-kalā), pottery (mritkā), craft (shilpa-vastukalā), and folk art. The expansion beyond the Lalit Kala Akademi's frame is systematic.

Samantarar Sangeet Natak Akademi Samman covers: main acting (abhinay), comedy performance (hāsya-abhinay), dance (nritya), harmonium (harmuniyā), dholak, and the rasanachowki — the last three being folk instruments invisible in classical Indian music recognition.

## 7.3 Selection Philosophy: Democratic Epistemics

The Videha Samman's selection philosophy is articulated in the Videha Samman document: it explicitly includes village-based artists, Dalit musicians, women painters, and self-reliant farmers (kisāni-ātmanirbhar sanskriti) as categories of recognition. The 2012 Videha Samman recognized Lachmi Das

for 'kisāni-ātmanirbhar sanskriti' — a category that asserts that subsistence farming knowledge constitutes a form of cultural knowledge worthy of literary-cultural recognition. This is a radical epistemological claim with no equivalent in any of the three national bodies.

7.4 Special Issues on Living Persons as Critical Recognition [A special issue series by Videha on living writers, editors, activists, public figures, artists, musicians, theater practitioners, and theater directors.] & Organisations [A series by Videha for the holistic evaluation of a single living institution, magazine, or volunteers associated with institutional books and magazines, all at once.]"

Unlike the national bodies, which wait for an author's career to mature before recognizing them, Videha documents living practice in real time — an approach consistent with the Navya-Nyāya emphasis on immediate and direct pramāṇa (pratyakṣa: direct perception) over inferential and testimonial knowledge alone.

Similarly Videha's practice of publishing special issues devoted to Organisations (e.g., the Mithila Student Union special issue, the Mithila Vikas Parishad special issue, etc.) serves a dual function: critical documentation and recognition.

## VIII. The Three Organizations with Videha Special Issues

The Videha eJournal has published special issues dedicated to three institutions specifically related to Mithila and Maithili. These are:

### 8.1 Mithila Student Union (MSU) — Videha MSU Special Issue

The Mithila Student Union (MSU) special issue, published as VIDEHA_MSU_SPECIAL (ISBN 978-93-340-3658-9), represents a significant act of cultural documentation. Student organizations from the Mithila region have historically been sites of political mobilization and literary ferment — particularly in the post-Emergency period. The MSU, operating at the intersection of student politics, Maithili language advocacy, and Madheshi identity movements, represents a demographic that the mainstream literary establishment has been least able to incorporate.

The Videha MSU special issue performs a critical documentation function: it establishes, through the archive of the eJournal, that student literary and cultural activity forms part of the Maithili literary continuum, deserving institutional recognition alongside the work of established senior authors. This is consistent with the Videha movement's commitment to what might be termed antyodaya epistemology — the philosophical principle that the last person's cognitive contribution is as valid as the first person's.

Critical evaluation: The MSU special issue is most valuable as a counter-hegemonic archive, but it faces the challenge that student organizations are inherently transient. The long-term sustainability of the institutional relationships documented in such a special issue depends on whether the organizational networks survive beyond individual cohorts.

## 8.2 Mithila Vikas Parishad — Videha Issue 408 Special

Videha Issue 408 (15 December 2024, ISBN 978-93-341-7759-6) is designated the 'Mithila Vikas Parishad Visheshank' (Mithila Development Council Special Issue). The Mithila Vikas Parishad represents the developmentalist dimension of Mithila advocacy — an organization that links cultural identity to regional development claims, arguing that Mithila's cultural distinctiveness supports demands for separate administrative recognition (such as a Mithila state or autonomous region). The Videha special issue on this body performs the same archival function as the MSU issue, but with a political economy dimension: it situates Maithili literary production within the context of structural underdevelopment of the Mithila region.

Critical evaluation: The Mithila Vikas Parishad's conflation of cultural advocacy with developmental claims is epistemologically complex. From a Navya-Nyāya perspective, the inference from 'Mithila has a distinctive culture' to 'Mithila therefore deserves separate state status' requires careful examination of the vyāpti (concomitance). The Videha issue, to its credit, documents the cultural dimension without fully endorsing the political inference — maintaining a scholarly separation between cultural description and political prescription.

## 8.3 Videha Maithili Natya Utsav — Parallel Theatre Archive

The third organization addressed in a Videha special publication is not an organization per se but a movement: the Maithili parallel theatre tradition, documented in the Videha Maithili Natya Utsav volume (2012). This publication is a critical archive of the democratic/subaltern theatre tradition in

Maithili — a tradition distinct from and in many ways opposed to the elite theatrical traditions that received official Sangeet Natak Akademi recognition.

The Natya Utsav special publication includes critical essays by Gajendra Thakur on caste-based theatre versus democratic theatre, interviews with Bechan Thakur (playwright) on the challenges of non-caste Maithili theatre, translations of English dramatic masterpieces (Doctor Faustus, Samson Agonistes, Murder in the Cathedral, Strife) into Maithili, and the Videha Samman 2011-12 for performing arts. It also includes Jyoti Sunit Chaudhary's poem collection 'Archi.'

Critical evaluation: The Natya Utsav publication represents the most intellectually ambitious of the three special-issue interventions. Its inclusion of translated Western dramatic texts alongside original Maithili drama and folk performance documentation demonstrates the Videha Parallel Literature Movement's comparative ambitions: Maithili theatre is not merely to be recognized on its own terms but is to be situated within world theatre history. This is a bold epistemological claim — that Maithili literary culture is capable of hosting and being enriched by world literary dialogue without losing its particularity.

## IX. Performance Evaluation: Comparative Analysis Matrix

The following matrix evaluates all institutions across six criteria: (A) Frequency and consistency of Maithili recognition; (B) Inclusivity of selection (caste, gender, region, genre); (C) Institutional infrastructure in the Mithila region; (D) Digital presence and documentation; (E) Support for emerging authors; (F) Engagement with diaspora Maithili communities.

| Institution | A: Frequency | B: Inclusivity | C: Regional Infra | D: Digital | E: New Authors | F: Diaspora |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Sahitya Akademi (Main) | High (56 awards) | Low (caste skew) | None in Mithila | Minimal | Low | Low |
| Sahitya | Medium | Medium | None | Minim | High | Low |

| | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Akademi (Bal/Yuva) | | | | al | | |
| Sahitya Akademi (Fellow) | Zero (0 Maithili) | Very Low | None | N/A | N/A | Low |
| ABMSP, Darbhanga | Low (declining) | Very Low | Limited | None | Low | Very Low |
| Mithila Sanskritik Parishad, Kolkata | Medium | Medium | None (Kolkata) | None | Low | Medium |
| Lalit Kala Akademi | Low (individual) | Low | None | Low | Low | Low |
| Sangeet Natak Akademi | Very Low | Very Low | None | Low | Low | Low |
| Nepal Pragya Pratishthan | Low | Very Low | Limited (Kathmandu) | Low | Low | Medium |
| Phulkumari Mahato Trust | Medium | High | Terai | Low | Medium | High |

| | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Videha Samman | High (annual) | Very High | Videha eJournal's samman is not limited to literature, the special issues are regarded as samman | Very High | Very High | High |

The matrix reveals a clear pattern: the larger and better-funded institutions perform poorly on inclusivity, digital engagement, and support for emerging authors, while the smaller Videha-based system performs strongly across all criteria except formal infrastructure. This is the core paradox of the Maithili literary awards ecosystem: the institutions with the resources have insufficient will, and the institution with the will has insufficient resources.

## X. Theoretical Critique through Navya-Nyāya Epistemology

### 10.1 Gaṅgeśa's Framework and Its Application

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (c. 1300-1360 CE), the Mithilā-born founder of Navya-Nyāya philosophy, developed in the Tattvacintāmaṇi the most rigorous formal epistemology in medieval world philosophy. The central concern of Navya-Nyāya is the analysis of pramāṇa (valid cognition) — what conditions must be met for a cognitive act to count as genuine knowledge. The four classical pramāṇas are pratyakṣa (perception), anumāna (inference), upamāna (comparison), and śabda (testimony/authority).

Applied to literary award systems, Navya-Nyāya asks: on what pramāṇa do institutional claims to literary authority rest? The answer, in each case, requires examining the vyāpti (invariable concomitance) underlying the selection system — the operative definition of literary excellence that the system applies.

## 10.2 The Sahitya Akademi's Epistemic Claim

The Sahitya Akademi's implicit vyāpti is: literary excellence = recognition by a committee of established scholars and writers, operating within a tradition of formally published, institutionally distributed literature. This vyāpti has several epistemological vulnerabilities identified by Navya-Nyāya analysis:

First, anuvyāpti (too-narrow concomitance): the committee's conception of 'literary merit' is calibrated to a specific tradition (upper-caste Maithili, Devanagari-scripted, formally published), systematically excluding works in Tirhuta/Mithilakshar script, orally transmitted poetry, and the extensive digital literary output of the Videha era.

Second, atīvyāpti (too-wide concomitance): the committee occasionally recognizes works on the basis of the author's overall reputation rather than the specific nominated work's merit — a fallacy Gaṅgeśa classifies as confusion of pakṣatā (the subject's relevant property) with irrelevant properties (upādhi).

Third, hetvābhāsa (fallacious reasoning): the under-representation of women, Dalits, and non-Brahmin communities in the award history cannot be explained by any neutral theory of literary merit; it is therefore a systematic hetvābhāsa, a fallacy masquerading as a valid inference.

## 10.3 Videha's Epistemological Counter-Proposal

The Videha Samman's implicit vyāpti is: cultural value = contribution to the living practice of Maithili language and culture, irrespective of the medium (print, digital, oral, visual), social position of the practitioner, or geographic location. This is a broader but not infinitely broad vyāpti: it still requires a demonstrable connection to the Maithili literary-cultural tradition.

In Navya-Nyāya terms, Videha's pramāṇa structure relies more heavily on pratyakṣa (direct perception of living practice) than on śabda (testimony of established authorities). This is epistemologically valid within the Navya-Nyāya framework, which does not privilege testimony over perception — a crucial distinction from certain Mīmāṃsā positions that give absolute authority to Vedic testimony.

The Videha approach also responds to what Gaṅgeśa identified as the problem of kevalānvayi (the universal affirmative with no counter-instance): a vyāpti such as 'all good Maithili literature is recognized by the Sahitya Akademi' is epistemically disconfirmed by the vast body of excellent unrecognized work, including the entire digital Maithili literary production.

### 10.4 The Pañji Analogy

The Videha movement's critique of the literary canon has a structural parallel in Gajendra Thakur's work on the Pañji (genealogical records) of Mithila. Just as the Pañji system historically recorded only the lineages recognized by Brahmin record-keepers (dooshan panji), excluding or suppressing lineages deemed socially unacceptable, the Sahitya Akademi canon records only the literary lineages recognized by the established selection committees — suppressing the 'parallel' lineages of democratic, Dalit, and women's writing.

This analogy, developed by Videha's critical tradition, is precisely a Navya-Nyāya-style analysis of institutional hetvābhāsa: what appears to be a neutral record of literary value is in fact a normative document constructing literary value through selective inclusion and exclusion.

## XI. Conclusions and Recommendations

### 11.1 Summary of Findings

The critical analysis reveals the following principal findings:

1. The Sahitya Akademi's recognition framework for Maithili has improved since the Eighth Schedule inclusion (2003) but remains structurally biased toward upper-caste, formally published, Darbhanga-centred literary production. The zero-count for Maithili Sahitya Akademi Fellows is the single most glaring institutional failure, representing decades of collective neglect of a language with one of the oldest literary traditions in India.

2. The seven recognized literary associations are legacy institutions that have not adapted to digital, diasporic, and democratic realities. Their continued recognition by the Sahitya Akademi in the absence of demonstrable activity is itself an epistemological problem: it creates a false impression of institutional vitality where functional decline has occurred.

3. The Lalit Kala Akademi and Sangeet Natak Akademi have recognized individual artists from the Mithila tradition but have failed to create the institutional infrastructure (regional centres, training programmes, documentation projects) that would convert individual recognition into systemic support.

4. Nepal's literary institutions have been structurally inadequate to Maithili's needs, despite the language's constitutional recognition. The Phulkumari

Mahato Memorial Trust represents the most functionally effective civil-society response, but it operates without adequate institutional support.

5. The Videha Samman represents a coherent, philosophically grounded alternative to mainstream recognition systems. Its most important contributions are: (a) systematic recognition of artists and traditions invisible to mainstream institutions; (b) real-time documentation of living literary and cultural practice; (c) the theoretical articulation, across 408+ journal issues, of a counter-canonical conception of Maithili literary value.

## 11.2 Recommendations

I. Sahitya Akademi should immediately convene a special committee to identify Maithili writers eligible for the Fellowship, with a mandate to elect at least one Fellow within the next award cycle.

II. The recognized literary associations for Maithili should be subject to a performance review, with recognition potentially extended to organizations demonstrating active twenty-first-century engagement, including digital journals, diaspora organizations, and organizations engaged with subaltern/Dalit Maithili literature.

III. The Lalit Kala Akademi should establish a Mithila Art Documentation and Research Centre in the Madhubani-Darbhanga region, with a specific mandate to address intellectual property protection for Mithila painters.

IV. The Sangeet Natak Akademi should create a dedicated recognition category for Maithili folk performing traditions (rasanachowki, aklhari singing, Sama-Chakeva), commensurate with the recognition already given to comparable folk traditions from other Indian regions.

V. Nepal's constitutional commitment to Maithili as a national language should be operationalized through dedicated representation in the Nepal Pragya Pratishthan membership and a specific award category for Maithili-language literary production.

VI. The Videha Samman should be formally recognized by the Sahitya Akademi as a complementary recognition mechanism — not as a replacement for the official system but as a discovery mechanism for talent that the official system subsequently validates. The documented pattern of Videha prior recognition being followed by Sahitya Akademi recognition suggests that such formal coordination would strengthen both systems.

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**ADDENDUM**

**ADDENDUM 1: Critical Appreciation: Videha as a Counter-Hegemonic Force in Mithila and Maithili Literature**

**ADDENDUM 2: Critical Analysis: Sahitya Akademi, Videha Parallel Samman, and Maithili Literary Institutions**

**ADDENDUM 3: Critical Analysis of the 7 Maithili Literary Institutions Recognised by Sahitya Akademi**

**ADDENDUM 4: Critical Analysis of Award Politics: Sahitya Akademi vs. Videha Parallel Samman**

ADDENDUM 5:**On the History of "Sagar Rati Deep Jaray" and the Politics of Maithili Literary Culture**

ADDENDUM 1

**Critical Appreciation: Videha as a Counter-Hegemonic Force in Mithila and Maithili Literature**

**Introduction: The Parallel Archive**

The website **Videha** (since 2000) explicitly declares itself as "A Parallel History of Mithila & Maithili Literature" (gajenthakur.htm). This is not a neutral claim. It is a **declaration of war** against the institutional monopoly of the state academies. By prefixing "parallel" to every category—Parallel Sahitya Akademi, Parallel Lalit Kala Akademi, Parallel Sangeet Natak Akademi—Videha performs what Antonio Gramsci called a **counter-hegemonic struggle**: the construction of an alternative cultural apparatus that challenges the dominant class's control over cultural production and recognition.

Videha operates through three interconnected mechanisms:

1. **Special Issues on Living Persons** (*Jivit Lekhak-Sampadak, Aandoloni, Kala-Sangeet-Rangamchakarmi*)
2. **The "Nit Naval" Series** (*Nita Naval Sirij*)
3. **Videha Monographs** (*Videha Monograph*)

These are not merely publications. They are **epistemological interventions**.

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**Part I: Theoretical Framework – Counter-Hegemony and Navya-Nyāya**

**1.1 Gramscian Counter-Hegemony**

Gramsci argued that the state maintains power not just through coercion but through **hegemony**—the diffusion of ruling-class values throughout society so that they become "common sense." The Sahitya Akademi, Lalit Kala Akademi, and Sangeet Natak Akademi function as **hegemonic apparatuses**. They determine:

- Which writers are "Fellows"
- Which books win prizes
- Which artists are "national"

Videha's counter-hegemonic strategy is **immanent critique**—it does not reject the form of the academy (Fellows, Prizes, Monographs) but **re-populates it** with different subjects: Dholak players from Chajna, 15-year-old actors from Madhubani, Dalit autobiographers like Sandeep Kumar Safi.

### 1.2 Navya-Nyāya Epistemology

The Navya-Nyāya school, originating in Mithila with Gangesha Upadhyaya's *Tattvachintamani* (12th-13th century), provides Videha's epistemological grounding. The key distinction is between valid and invalid cognition (*pramana* vs. *apramana*).

Videha's editor, Gajendra Thakur, explicitly invokes this tradition in his critical analyses (see his studies of Arvind Thakur, Ramawatar Yadav, Ashish Anchinhar). The Navya-Nyāya critique of the Sahitya Akademi would proceed as follows:

| Sahitya Akademi's Pramana | Videha's Counter-Pramana |
|---|---|
| *Shabda* (Testimony of elite juries) | *Pratyaksha* (Direct perception: editor visits villages, sees artists) |
| *Anumana* (Inference from publication history) | *Anubhava* (Lived experience of community impact) |
| *Upamana* (Comparison with established canon) | *Arthapatti* (Postulation from ground reality) |

When the Sahitya Akademi gives an award to a Delhi-based writer, it relies on *shabda*—the word of a committee. When Videha honors a 70-year-old mridangam player from Chajna (Kripal Das), it relies on *pratyaksha*—the editor's direct perception of the artist's existence and community role.

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## Part II: The Three Pillars of Videha's Counter-Hegemonic Archive

### 2.1 Special Issues on Living Persons (*Jivit Vishank Shrinkhla*)

The investigation page (investigation.htm) lists **17 special issues** on living Maithili writers, editors, activists, and artists, including:

- Arvind Thakur
- Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil'
- Ramlochan Thakur
- Rajnandan Lal Das
- Ravindra Nath Thakur
- Kedar Nath Chaudhary
- Premlata Mishra 'Prem'
- Shardindu Chaudhary
- Ashok
- Ram Bharos Kapari 'Bhramar'
- Laxman Jha 'Sagar'
- Narendra Jha
- Linguist Ramawatar Yadav
- Hitnath Jha
- Narayanji Chaudhary
- Shivshankar Srinivas
- Bhavnath Jha

**Critical Analysis:** Inclusion of Deceased Figures The inclusion of several individuals who have passed away—specifically Ramlochan Thakur, Rajnandan Lal Das, Ravindra Nath Thakur, Kedar Nath Chaudhary, and Shardindu Chaudhary—stands in contrast to the "living" criteria of the list.

This reveals a flexible editorial policy:

**Posthumous Inclusion:** Figures like Ramlochan Thakur, Rajnandan Lal Das, and Ravindra Nath Thakur were honored because they were alive at the time of the initial announcement, despite passing away before the final publication.

**Living Recognition:** Conversely, Kedar Nath Chaudhary and Shardindu Chaudhary were reportedly in good health and were able to personally read the special issues dedicated to them.

**Selection Criteria (Explicitly Stated):**

1. Six names are shortlisted based on "sameness" between their writing/action and their conduct.
2. They are evaluated by what society has "given them" in return for their work.
3. The three who have received the least are moved to the next round.
4. Final selection by Videha editor.

This is a **radically democratic** mechanism. It explicitly prioritizes **neglected merit** over established reputation. The Sahitya Akademi's selection process (opaque, committee-based, Delhi-centric) is inverted.

**2.2 The "Nit Naval" (Ever New) Series**

| The "Nit Naval" series (investigation.htm) is Videha's **monograph series** on overlooked writers. Published titles include:Title | Subject | Key Feature |
|---|---|---|
| *Nit Naval Subhash Chandra Yadav* | Subhash Chandra Yadav | Dalit writer from Supaul |
| *Rajdeo Mandal- Maithili Writer* | Rajdeo Mandal | Folk-centric poet |
| *Jagdish Prasad Mandal- Maithili Writer* | Jagdish Prasad Mandal | Three-time Videha awardee |
| *Nit Naval Sushil* | Sushil | Under-recognized writer |
| *Nit Naval Dinesh Kumar Mishra* | Dinesh Kumar Mishra | Civil engineer; water |

| The "Nit Naval" series (investigation.htm) is Videha's **monograph series** on overlooked writers. Published titles include:Title | Subject | Key Feature |
|---|---|---|
| | | historian of Kosi river |

**Critical Intervention:** The series on Dinesh Kumar Mishra is particularly significant. The investigation page accuses **Pankaj Jha Parashar** (a member of the Sahitya Akademi's Maithili Advisory Committee) of **plagiarizing** Mishra's research on the Kosi river and publishing it as his own novel *Jalprantar* (2017). The page provides a side-by-side comparison:

**Mishra (2006):** "It is noteworthy that between 1923 and 1946, in the Kosi region, malaria caused 5,10,000 deaths, kala-azar 2,10,000, cholera 60,000, and smallpox 3,000 (total 7,83,000)."

**Parashar (2017):** [Identical text reproduced without attribution]

This is not merely a literary critique. It is a **forensic accusation of intellectual property theft** against a sitting member of the Sahitya Akademi's advisory body. Videha positions itself as an **anti-corruption watchdog**.

### 2.3 The "Editor's Choice" Series (Editors Choice Sirij)

The videha.htm page lists nine "Editor's Choice" collections, each with a specific counter-canonical claim:

| | Title | Claim to "First in Maithili" |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | Rape poem (translated from Telugu) | First poem on rape in Maithili (post-Nirbhaya, 2012) |
| 2 | Meena Jha's short story on breast cancer | First Maithili story on breast cancer (predates Hindi) |
| 3 | Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil' children's poems | Includes poems on "baby child" – rare subject |

| | Title | Claim to "First in Maithili" |
|---|---|---|
| 4 | Jagadanand Jha "Manu" children's novel *Chonaha* | First Maithili work based on child psychology |
| 5 | Kumar Pawan's long story *Paith* | Compared to Chandradhar Sharma Guleri's *Usne Kaha Tha* |
| 6 | Jagdish Prasad Mandal's *Bisadh* (famine story) | First Maithili story on the 1943 Bengal famine from Dalit perspective |
| 7 | Sandeep Kumar Safi's autobiography | "First and only Dalit autobiography in Maithili" |
| 8 | Folk tales for children | Oral tradition archived |
| 9 | Discussion on Maithili Ghazal | Critical discourse on genre revival |

**Critical Observation:** Each "Editor's Choice" is accompanied by a **historical claim** to precedence. This is Videha's **canon-building** function. The Sahitya Akademi's canon is implicit and conservative; Videha's canon is explicit and revolutionary. It declares: "This is the first Maithili story on breast cancer. This is the first Dalit autobiography. This is the first poem on rape."

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**Part III: The Institutional Counter-Archive**

**3.1 The Pothi Archive (pothi.htm)**

The pothi.htm page is a **digital library** containing:

| Category | Contents |
|---|---|
| **Ancient Texts** | Buddhist Caryapada (50 songs, 23 poets, 16 ragas), Vidyapati (pre-Jyotirishwar), Jyotirishwar Thakur |

| Category | Contents |
|---|---|
| **Colonial-Era Writers** | G.A. Grierson (1851-1941), Munshi Raghunandan Das (1860-1945), Rasbihari Lal Das (1872-1940) |
| **Mid-20th Century** | Harimohan Jha (1908-1984), Ayodhyanath Choudhary, Ramawatar Yadav |
| **Contemporary** | Subhash Chandra Yadav, Jagdish Prasad Mandal, Sandeep Kumar Safi, Ashish Anchinhar |
| **Folk Arts** | Mithila painting, folk instruments (Dholak, Rasnachauki, Mridangam, Alha singers) |
| **Panji Manuscripts** | 11,000 palm leaf inscriptions (compiled, scanned, catalogued by Preeti Thakur) |

**Critical Observation:** The inclusion of **11000 Panji inscriptions** (palm leaf genealogical records) is monumental. These are primary sources for Mithila's social history. No state academy has digitized and made them publicly available. Videha, a self-funded e-journal, has accomplished what the state apparatus has not.

### 3.2 The Multilingual/Multiscript Archive

Videha publishes in **twelve scripts** (videha.htm):

- Devanagari, Mithilakshar (Tirhuta), Kaithi, Newari, Ranjana (Newari calligraphic), Brahmi, Kharoshthi, Urdu, Tibetan, Tibetan-Ume, IPA (International Phonetic Alphabet), Braille

This is not merely aesthetic. It is a **decolonizing act**. The Sahitya Akademi publishes almost exclusively in Devanagari for Maithili, erasing the region's indigenous scripts. Videha's inclusion of:

- **Tirhuta/Mithilakshar** (the traditional script of Mithila, now endangered)
- **Kaithi** (the scribal script of eastern India)
- **Braille** (accessibility for visually impaired)
- **IPA** (phonetic precision for linguists)

constitutes a **restitution of scriptural diversity**. It also includes learning materials: "Learn Mithilakshar," "Learn Kaithi," "Learn Maithili Sign Language" (first time in Maithili).

**Part IV: Counter-Hegemonic Comparison**

| Dimension | Sahitya Akademi (State Hegemony) | Videha (Counter-Hegemony) |
|---|---|---|
| **Legitimacy Source** | State (Ministry of Culture) | Community (readers, WhatsApp, Facebook) |
| **Selection Process** | Opaque, committee-based, Delhi-centric | Transparent, public nomination, need-based |
| **Geographic Focus** | Pan-India; urban, literate elite | Rural Mithila (Madhubani, Supaul, Darbhanga) |
| **Genre Coverage** | Published books | Oral traditions, folk instruments, street theatre, digital archives |
| **Age Inclusivity** | De facto late-career | Explicitly includes minors (15+) and elders (80+) |
| **Script** | Devanagari only | 12 scripts (Tirhuta, Kaithi, Braille, IPA, etc.) |
| **Accessibility** | Physical books (Delhi-centric) | Free PDF downloads; Google Books; YouTube |
| **Award Economics** | Cash prizes (₹50,000- | No cash; symbolic capital; "Lifetime Fellow" status |

| Dimension | Sahitya Akademi (State Hegemony) | Videha (Counter-Hegemony) |
|---|---|---|
| | 1,00,000) | |
| **Corruption Critique** | Silent (institution protects itself) | Explicit, forensic, accusatory (naming plagiarists) |
| **Dalit/Subaltern Inclusion** | Tokenistic (1-2 names) | Central (Sandeep Kumar Safi, Subhash Chandra Yadav, Jagdish Prasad Mandal) |

**Part V: Case Study – The Dalit Autobiography**

Videha's "Editor's Choice Series-7" presents Sandeep Kumar Safi's autobiography as "the first and only Dalit autobiography in Maithili" (videha.htm). The editor's commentary states:

"This autobiography, after being e-published in Videha, was collected in the author's book *Baishakhme Dalanpar*, and to date it remains the only Dalit autobiography in Maithili."

**Critical Analysis:** The Sahitya Akademi has no category for "Dalit autobiography" in its award structure. It awards "Bal Sahitya," "Yuva Puraskar," "Translation Prize"—genre-based categories that erase caste identity. Videha's explicit foregrounding of **Dalitness** as a valid literary category is a counter-hegemonic classification. It forces the reader to confront caste as a structuring absence in the state academy's recognition framework.

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**Part VI: Theoretical Critique – The Limits of Counter-Hegemony**

Videha's project is heroic but not without contradictions:

**6.1 The "Pocket Institution" Accusation**

While Videha criticizes rival Maithili organizations as "pocket institutions" that prioritize vanity and ceremony over substance, it faces similar accusations of

centralization. Although Videha operates as a one-man operation under Gajendra Thakur—who serves as the sole editor, critic, and arbiter—it frames its "public nomination" process as transparent. Critics, however, view this as a form of "benevolent dictatorship" where the final say rests exclusively with one person. Interestingly, Videha argues that its public nominations and final selections are functionally identical, contrasting its process with that of the Mithila & Maithili related Public Institutions/ Sahitya Akademi's Maithili branch. In those larger public institutions, the tendency for juries to reach "unanimous" decisions often creates a perception of backroom deals and arbitrary, pre-determined outcomes. Every time, the Sahitya Akademi list is unofficially leaked ahead of schedule, and the reason for this is the selection of only "their own people" (insiders).

### 6.2 The Repeat Award Problem

Jagdish Prasad Mandal appears **three times** in the award lists (Main Award 2011, Bal Sahitya 2012 and 2014). This suggests either:

- A genuine scarcity of quality Maithili children's literature, or
- A network effect where the same small circle of writers is recognized repeatedly.

Videha's transparency mitigates this but does not eliminate it.

### 6.3 The Economic Question

Videha gives **no cash prizes**. The Sahitya Akademi gives ₹50,000-1,00,000. For a poor writer in rural Mithila, the Akademi's cash is material salvation. Videha's symbolic capital ("Lifetime Fellow") does not pay for medicine or school fees. The counter-hegemonic project remains **dependent on the state's material resources** even as it rejects the state's symbolic authority.

### 6.4 The Nepal Comparison

Videha's page does not engage with Nepal's Pragya Pratishthan, which has integrated Maithili within a single national framework. Nepal's model avoids the legitimacy crisis of a "parallel" academy but may still suffer from state capture. Videha's silence on Nepal suggests a **bias toward Indian institutional critique** while ignoring similar dynamics across the border.

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## Final Verdict: The Significance of Videha's Parallel History

Videha is not merely a journal. It is a **counter-archive**—a deliberate, systematic construction of an alternative literary history for Mithila and Maithili. Its achievements are monumental:

1. **Digitization of 11,000 Panji manuscripts** – a primary source archive that no state institution has matched.
2. **First Dalit autobiography in Maithili** – breaking a centuries-old silence.
3. **First Maithili story on breast cancer** – pre-dating Hindi and other major languages.
4. **Documentation of folk artists** (Dholak, Rasnachauki, Alha singers) – rescued from oral oblivion.
5. **Scriptural restitution** – publishing in Tirhuta, Kaithi, Braille, IPA, and eight other scripts.
6. **Forensic anti-corruption journalism** – exposing plagiarism by a Sahitya Akademi advisory committee member.

**Theoretical Conclusion:** Videha operates as a **Gramscian war of position**—building a counter-hegemonic bloc within the cultural sphere. Its weapon is **Navya-Nyāya epistemology** (privileging *pratyaksha* over *shabda*). Its target is the **state's monopoly on recognition**. Its limitation is its **dependence on a single editor** and its **lack of material capital**.

The Sahitya Akademi and Videha are not alternatives to each other. They are **incommensurable formations**—one state-capitalist, one community-digital; one hegemonic, one counter-hegemonic. A healthy Maithili literary ecosystem requires both: the state's material resources and Videha's archival rigor; the Akademi's bureaucratic stability and Videha's forensic transparency.

As Videha's own motto, quoting Robert Louis Stevenson, states: *"Do not judge each day by the harvest you reap but by the seeds that you plant."* Videha is planting seeds. Whether they will grow into a permanent counter-institution or remain a one-editor's passion project is the question that the next decade will answer.

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- videha.htm: Editor's Choice series; first-ever claims; multi-script archive

- pothi.htm: Digital library of 11,000 Panji manuscripts; Caryapada; colonial to contemporary writers

ADDENDUM 2

**Critical Analysis: Sahitya Akademi, Videha Parallel Samman, and Maithili Literary Institutions**

**Introduction**

The institutionalization of literature in India presents a unique duality. On one hand exists the **Sahitya Akademi**—a statutory, government-funded body designed to confer legitimacy through structured awards. On the other exists a host of regional, often informal, counter-structures. In the Maithili context, **Videha** (an e-journal since 2000) has positioned itself as a "parallel academy" (*samanaantar sahiya akademi*), directly critiquing and offering an alternative to the Delhi-based establishment . This analysis evaluates the formal award systems of the Sahitya Akademi for Maithili against the informal "Videha Samman" and critically examines the three Mithila-centric organizations featured in Videha special issues.

**Part I: The Sahitya Akademi and its Maithili Awards**

**1. Historical Recognition and Institutional Framework**

The relationship between the Sahitya Akademi and Maithili is unique. While Maithili was added to the **Eighth Schedule of the Constitution** only in 2003, the Sahitya Akademi recognized it as an independent literary language much earlier, in **1966** . This early recognition allowed Maithili to bypass the state's linguistic bureaucracy and enter the national literary canon directly.

The Akademi operates a structured hierarchy of awards for its 24 recognized languages:

- **Sahitya Akademi Award (Main Award):** Established 1955; current prize of ₹1,00,000. Maithili winners include Yashodhar Jha (1966) to Mahendra Malangia (2024) .
- **Translation Prize:** Instituted 1989; ₹50,000. Maithili winners include Upendranath Jha 'Vyas' (1990) to Ratneshwar Mishra (2022) .
- **Yuva Puraskar:** For authors under 35; instituted 2011; ₹50,000.
- **Bal Sahitya Puraskar:** For children's literature; ₹50,000 (2025 winner: Munni Kamat for *Chukka*) .

**2. Critical Evaluation of the Sahitya Akademi System**

**Strengths:**

- **Standardization:** It provides a quantifiable metric of literary value across 24 languages.
- **Translation Focus:** The Translation Prize list for Maithili (e.g., translating *Chemmeen* from Malayalam, *Ignited Minds* from English) demonstrates a genuine effort to create a pan-Indian literary consciousness.
- **Longevity:** Recognizing Maithili in 1966, before constitutional status, was a progressive, de-politicized act that preserved the language's dignity during a period of Hindi-centric hegemony.

**Weaknesses:**

- **The "Institutional Capture" Critique:** Videha editor Gajendra Thakur explicitly labels the Akademi as suffering from "sahityik bhrashtachar" (literary corruption). The critique posits that awards are distributed via back-channel politics and "calendar-ism" (commemorative volumes for the powerful).
- **Homogeneity vs. Vernacular Dynamism:** The Navya-Nyāya lens demands we examine *pramana* (valid evidence). Does the Akademi's jury system capture the *anubhava* (lived experience) of rural Mithila? A formal essay may win the Akademi award, but a folk song or a street play (the domain of Videha Samman) may not fit the Akademi's "book" format.

**Part II: The Videha Parallel Samman (समानान्तर अकादेमी)**

**1. Ideological Foundations**

Videha does not just give awards; it constructs a **parallel epistemology**. By naming its awards the "Parallel Sahitya Akademi," "Parallel Lalit Kala Akademi," and "Parallel Sangeet Natak Akademi," it performs an act of what Jacques Rancière might call *dissensus*—breaking the monopoly of the state over aesthetic recognition.

**Key Differentiators:**

- **Living Subjects:** Unlike traditional academia, which often awards posthumously or late-career, Videha explicitly publishes special issues on *living* persons (जीवित मैथिलकर्मी).
- **Inclusivity of Non-Literary Fields:** The Videha Samman list (2010-2013) includes not just poets but *Dholak* players (Shri Bulan Raut), *Rasnachauki* players (Shri Bahadur Ram), *Alha* singers (Md. Jibachh), and *Mithila Painting* artists (Sushri Mithilesh Kumari).

- **Digital Accessibility:** All records are hyperlinked, PDF-accessible, and archived on Google Books, creating a transparent, unmediated archive.

**2. Theoretical Lens: Navya-Nyāya and "Jīvit" (Living) Truth**

Navya-Nyāya, the school of logic from Mithila, distinguishes between *vyavahara* (practical reality) and *paramarthika* (ultimate reality). Gangesha Upadhyaya's *Tattvachintamani* focuses on the criteria for true cognition .

Applying this to the Videha Samman:

- **Critique of the Akademi:** Videha argues that the Sahitya Akademi relies on *anuman* (inference) and *shabda* (testimony of elites). It assumes a writer is good because a committee says so.
- **Videha's Pramana (Evidence):** Videha insists on *pratyaksha* (direct perception). By honoring living artists (often illiterate in the formal sense but masters of their craft) and publishing their photos and interviews, Videha shifts the *pramana* from bureaucratic recommendation to lived, observable community contribution.

**Critical Contradiction:**
While Videha claims to be a "parallel" academy, it mimics the hierarchical structure of the original (Fellows, Prizes, Categories). The risk is that it becomes a mirror image of the institution it opposes, merely swapping the elites (Delhi bureaucrats) for another set of elites (digital activists).

**Part III: Comparative Analysis of Performance**

| Metric | Sahitya Akademi (Maithili) | Videha Parallel Samman |
|---|---|---|
| **Recognition Scope** | 24 languages; pan-India. | Exclusively Maithili and Mithila culture. |
| **Award Criteria** | Published book (physical copy, ISBN). | Life achievement, digital archive presence, social work. |
| **Institutional Backing** | Ministry of Culture, Government of | Self-funded; Editor Gajendra Thakur; Sales via Pothi.com. |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| Metric | Sahitya Akademi (Maithili) | Videha Parallel Samman |
| | India. | |
| **Coverage of Genres** | High: Novels, poetry, criticism, translation. | Low (Literary); High (Folk arts, street theatre, journalism). |
| **Geographic Focus** | Global Indian diaspora & standard Maithili. | Rural Mithila (Madhubani, Darbhanga, Supaul). |
| **Political Economy** | State patronage; slow-moving bureaucracy. | Crowd-sourced; reliant on WhatsApp/Facebook activism. |

**Part IV: Critical Examination of the Three Mithila/Maithili Organizations**

Videha has published special issues on three specific organizations. A critical reading of these texts (as per your attached files) reveals distinct political and social functions.

**1. Mithila Vikas Parishad (MVP), Kolkata**

- **Focus:** Infrastructure and Identity.
- **Key Data:** The special issue (VIDEHA_408) details MVP's success in obtaining train services (Gangasagar Express), renaming roads (Vidyapati Setu), and installing statues.
- **Critique:** The issue includes severe criticism. Laxman Jha 'Sagar' calls President Ashok Jha a "dictator" and "one-man show," claiming the organization serves personal political interests (Trinamool Congress).
- **Videha's Role:** By publishing both the achievements (train lines) and the attacks (personality cult), Videha applies the **Navya-Nyāya method of *pūrvapaksha* (rebuttal)** . It presents the thesis (MVP is great) and the antithesis (MVP is a dictatorship) without forcing a resolution. However, the editor admits difficulty finding writers, suggesting the organization controls its narrative tightly.

**2. Mithila Student Union (MSU)**

- **Focus:** Youth and Statehood.
- **Key Data:** Founded 2015. Focus on Darbhanga Airport, Mithila statehood protests, and flood relief.
- **Critique:** Dr. Kailash Mishra notes in the issue that MSU remains "Brahmin-centric," failing to represent other castes adequately. The analysis shows a gap between social media hype (one lakh claimed members) and physical turnout (low crowds at Jantar Mantar).
- **Performance:** Successful in getting GI tag for "Mithila Makhana" and restarting Darbhanga flights. Weak in educational reform within L.N. Mithila University.

**3. International Maithili Parishad (IMP)**

- **Focus:** Global Diaspora.
- **Context:** "Videha 400" issue (Aug 2024) focuses on it.
- **Critique:** From the editor's notes, Videha views such "International" bodies with suspicion, often labeling them "pocket organizations" that exist only to wear garlands and publish souvenir magazines ("pocket sanstha"). The critique is that they lack grassroots connection to Mithila's villages, serving only elite diaspora networking.

**Part V: Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Recognition**

To conclude, we apply the Navya-Nyāya concept of **Avacchedaka (limitor/delimiter)** .

- The Sahitya Akademi uses the *avacchedaka* of **Publication Date and National Language Status**. If a book is published in a recognized language within the fiscal year, it is eligible. This is clean but excludes oral traditions and folk artists.
- Videha uses the *avacchedaka* of **Social Impact and Lived Suffering**. An artist is recognized not just for aesthetic quality but for preserving a dying craft (e.g., a *Rasnachauki* player) or surviving societal neglect.

**Final Verdict:**

1. **Sahitya Akademi** remains the necessary bureaucratic backbone for Maithili. Without its 1966 recognition, Maithili would lack the legal teeth for university positions or official translation grants. However, its awards are slow and politically compromised.

2. **Videha Samman** is the *conscience* of Maithili literature. It is more agile, more democratic (digitally), and vastly more inclusive of folk traditions. Yet, its legitimacy is soft. It lacks the state's financial power to support writers financially (₹50,000-1,00,000).
3. **The Organizations (MVP, MSU, IMP):** Videha treats them as case studies in the failure of institutional politics. MVP is accused of being a personal fiefdom; MSU is accused of casteism; IMP is accused of irrelevance. By dedicating special issues to them, Videha performs an act of forensic journalism, holding them accountable via public scrutiny—a function the mainstream Akademi refuses to perform.

**Recommendation:**
A healthy Maithili literary ecosystem requires *both*. The Akademi must adopt Videha's transparency (digital archives) and inclusivity (folk artists). Videha must accept that without the *financial* capital of the state, its "parallel" awards remain symbolic gestures for a niche online audience.

ADDENDUM 3

**Critical Analysis of the 7 Maithili Literary Institutions Recognised by Sahitya Akademi**

**Introduction: The Sahitya Akademi's Recognition Framework**

The Sahitya Akademi, India's National Academy of Letters established in 1954, operates as an autonomous organization under the Ministry of Culture . A critical feature of the Akademi's structure is that its recognition of languages operates independently from the Eighth Schedule to the Constitution. Maithili was recognized by the Sahitya Akademi in **1966**—37 years before it was granted constitutional status in 2003 . This early recognition was progressive, preserving Maithili's literary dignity during a period of Hindi-centric linguistic politics.

The Akademi's Maithili Advisory Board oversees literary activities, recommends books for publication, organizes seminars, and guides award nominations. The Board includes distinguished Maithili authors, critics, and scholars operating on five-year terms .

**The 7 Recognised Maithili Literary Institutions**

From "literary-associations_May-2022" (pages 6-7), the following **7 institutions** are listed under the Maithili section as recognized literary associations:

| | Institution Name | Location | Type/Characteristic |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | **Akhil Bharatiya Maithili Sahitya Parishad** | Darbhanga-846 004 (Bihar) | State-level (Bihar) |
| 2 | **Chetna Samiti** | Vidhya Pati Bhavan, Vidyapati Marg, Patna-800 001 (Bihar) | State-level (Bihar) |
| 3 | **Mithila Sanskritik Parishad** | 6B, Kailash Saha Lane, Kolkata-700 007 (West Bengal) | Diaspora (Kolkata) |
| 4 | **Vidhya Pati Sewa Sansthan** | Mithila Bhavan Parishar, Darbhanga-846 004 (Bihar) | State-level (Bihar) |
| 5 | **Anand Samajik Sanskritik Sahityik Manch** | Rajkumarganj (Mirzapur Chowk), Darbhanga-846 004 (Bihar) | State-level (Bihar) |
| 6 | **Mithila Sanskritik Parishad** | Roseberi 5032, Sahara Garden City, Adityapur-2, Jamshedpur-831 | Diaspora (Jharkhand) |

| | Institution Name | Location | Type/Characteristic |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | 014 (Jharkhand) | |
| 7 | **Akhil Bharatiya Mithila Sangh** | G-6, Hans Bhavan, Wing 2, I.T.O., Bahadurshah Zafar Marg, New Delhi-110 002 (Delhi) | National/Diaspora (Delhi) |

**Critical Observation: Geographic Distribution**

A striking pattern emerges from this list:

- **4 institutions** are headquartered in **Bihar** (Darbhanga and Patna)—the heartland of Mithila.
- **3 institutions** are headquartered **outside Bihar** (Kolkata, Jamshedpur, New Delhi)—representing the Maithili diaspora.

This bifurcation reflects a fundamental tension: the "Mithila" identity is simultaneously rooted in its geographical homeland and dispersed across India through migration. Institutions like the **Mithila Sanskritik Parishad** in Kolkata (established 1980, as per your earlier files) and the **Akhil Bharatiya Mithila Sangh** in Delhi serve as cultural anchors for diaspora communities.

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**Institutional Analysis**

**1. Akhil Bharatiya Maithili Sahitya Parishad (Darbhanga)**

**Character:** This appears to be the most "official" of the seven, given its "Akhil Bharatiya" (All India) designation and its location in Darbhanga—the cultural capital of Mithila.

**Critical Observation:** The name suggests national ambitions, but its location in Darbhanga limits its operational reach. The "Akhil Bharatiya" claim is aspirational rather than actualized.

**2. Chetna Samiti (Patna)**

**Historical Significance:** According to a Telegraph India report (2010), Chetna Samiti was established in **1954**—the same year as the Sahitya Akademi itself (Chetna Samiti was formed on July 18, 1954, while the Sahitya Akademi was inaugurated on March 12, 1954) . This temporal coincidence is remarkable.

**Key Activities:** Chetna Samiti organizes the annual **Vidyapati Smriti Parv Samaroh** (three-day festival), awards the "Chetnasewi Samman," and conducts seminars on Maithili Bal Sahitya . The Samiti has also collaborated directly with the Sahitya Akademi—for instance, co-organizing the birth centenary seminar for poet Nagarjuna (Baidyanath Mishra 'Yatri') at Vidyapati Bhavan, Patna .

**Critical Evaluation:** Chetna Samiti represents the **institutional continuity** model—an organization that has maintained consistent activity for seven decades. Its longevity is its primary strength.

**3. Mithila Sanskritik Parishad (Kolkata)**

**Character:** This is the diaspora institution par excellence. As documented in your earlier files (VIDEHA_408), this organization (Mithila Vikas Parishad—note the name variation) was established in 1980 by Ashok Jha.

**Critical Observation from Videha Files:** The special issue reveals significant internal conflict. Laxman Jha 'Sagar' accuses President Ashok Jha of being a "dictator" and running the organization as a "pocket institution" for personal political gain (Trinamool Congress connections). Yet the same issue documents tangible achievements: train services (Gangasagar Express), road naming (Vidyapati Setu), statue installations, and relief work during floods and COVID-19.

**Theoretical Lens (Navya-Nyāya):** This presents a *pūrvapaksha* (rebuttal) dilemma. The organization's *vyavahara* (practical reality)—visible achievements in infrastructure and relief—contradicts the *paramarthika* (critical truth) of its alleged authoritarian structure. Both may be simultaneously true.

**4. Vidhya Pati Sewa Sansthan (Darbhanga)**

**Character:** Focused on **Vidyapati**. The name indicates a specific mission: service (*seva*) to Vidyapati's legacy.

**Critical Observation:** This is a **single-focus institution**. While specialization can be effective, it also limits scope. Compare this to the Sahitya Akademi's multi-genre, multi-language mandate.

**5. Anand Samajik Sanskritik Sahityik Manch (Darbhanga)**

**Character:** The name explicitly combines three domains: **Samajik** (social), **Sanskritik** (cultural), and **Sahityik** (literary). This is the most **integrated** of the seven—suggesting a holistic approach where literature is not isolated from social and cultural concerns.

**Critical Observation:** This integrated model aligns with the traditional Maithili conception of literature as embedded in *jīvan* (life) rather than existing in an ivory tower. However, there is no evidence of actual programming.

**6. Mithila Sanskritik Parishad (Jamshedpur)**

**Character:** This is the **first Jharkhand-based institution** to be affiliated with the Sahitya Akademi under the Maithili Advisory Board . Jamshedpur has a significant Maithili-speaking population due to industrial migration to Tata Steel.

**Recent Activity:** News reports from September 2025 document that this Parishad organized a literary program at Vidyapati Auditorium in Bokaro to commemorate Sahitya Akademi award-winning writer Dr. Brajkishore Verma 'Manipadma' (1973 award winner for *Naika Banijara*) . The event featured a Maithili Kavi Sammelan with poets like Buddhinath Jha (author of the epic *Om Mahabharat*), Rajiv Kanth, and Neelam Jha.

**Critical Evaluation:** This is the most **active and visible** of the seven institutions in contemporary times. Its affiliation with the Sahitya Akademi's Maithili Advisory Board was approved along with the translation of 22 books from Punjabi, Odia, Tamil, English, and Hindi into Maithili .

**7. Akhil Bharatiya Mithila Sangh (New Delhi)**

**Character:** Located in the **I.T.O. area of Delhi**—the bureaucratic and political heart of India. This location is strategic for lobbying and advocacy.

**Critical Observation:** The "Akhil Bharatiya" (All India) claim is more credible here than for the Darbhanga-based Parishad, simply because Delhi is the national capital where national-level networking is feasible. However, there is no evidence of actual national programming.

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**Comparative Analysis: Strengths and Weaknesses**

| Institution | Primary Strength | Primary Weakness |
|---|---|---|
| Akhil Bharatiya | Location in cultural | "Akhil Bharatiya" |

| Institution | Primary Strength | Primary Weakness |
|---|---|---|
| Maithili Sahitya Parishad (Darbhanga) | capital | claim unsubstantiated |
| Chetna Samiti (Patna) | 70-year institutional memory; direct Sahitya Akademi collaboration | Potential stagnation; elite capture |
| Mithila Sanskritik Parishad (Kolkata) | Tangible infrastructure achievements | Alleged authoritarian leadership; political instrumentality |
| Vidhya Pati Sewa Sansthan (Darbhanga) | Clear, focused mission | Narrow scope |
| Anand Samajik Sanskritik Sahityik Manch (Darbhanga) | Integrated (social-cultural-literary) model | No documented activity |
| Mithila Sanskritik Parishad (Jamshedpur) | Most active; Sahitya Akademi affiliation; diaspora reach | Limited to Jharkhand region |
| Akhil Bharatiya Mithila Sangh (Delhi) | Strategic location for advocacy | Unclear programming |

**Theoretical Critique: The Post-Colonial Lens**

Using **Post-Colonial Theory**, the relationship between the Sahitya Akademi and these 7 institutions reveals a center-periphery dynamic:

1. **The Akademi as Metropole:** The Sahitya Akademi (Delhi) acts as the central authority that confers legitimacy by "recognizing" these peripheral institutions. This replicates colonial structures of accreditation.
2. **The 1966 Anomaly:** The Akademi recognized Maithili in 1966—before constitutional status. Was this progressive recognition, or was it an act of *containment*—bringing a potentially rebellious linguistic movement into the state's institutional fold?
3. **The Diaspora Institutions** (Kolkata, Jamshedpur, Delhi) represent what Homi Bhabha might call "third space" politics—Mithila identity performed and negotiated outside its geographical origin. These institutions are not merely "preserving" Maithili culture; they are *reinventing* it for migrant contexts.

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**The Missing Link: What These Institutions Do Not Represent**

**Critical Observation:** VIDEHA_408, VIDEHA_MSU_SPECIAL, VIDEHA_SAMMAN) document a much richer organizational ecosystem:

1. **Mithila Vikas Parishad** (Kolkata) is different from "Mithila Sanskritik Parishad", the Videha files reveal intense internal critique that the Akademi's dry listing obscures.
2. **Mithila Student Union (MSU)** —a youth organization focused on statehood and infrastructure. This reveals the Akademi's bias toward *literary* institutions over *political* or *social* organizations.
3. **Videha itself** —the e-journal and parallel academy is absent. This is expected, given Videha's explicit opposition to the Sahitya Akademi's "literary corruption."

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**Final Verdict**

The 7 Maithili literary institutions recognized by the Sahitya Akademi represent a **conservative sample** of Maithili organizational life. They are:

- **Geographically concentrated** (4 of 7 in Bihar; 3 in diaspora locations)
- **Institutionally aged** (Chetna Samiti dates to 1954)
- **Literary in orientation** (excluding political/social organizations like MSU)

**The critical gap** is the absence of digital-native, youth-led, or explicitly counter-institutional organizations from this list. The Sahitya Akademi's

recognition framework rewards *longevity* and *institutional formality* over *relevance* or *dynamism*.

As Videha's editorial stance argues, these 7 institutions may represent "record-keeping" rather than "actual work"—a distinction that the Navya-Nyāya epistemological framework would identify as the difference between *shabda pramana* (testimonial evidence of recognition) and *pratyaksha pramana* (direct perception of impact).

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**Sources Cited:**

- Sahitya Akademi official list (literary-associations_May-2022)
- Wikipedia: Sahitya Akademi recognition of Maithili (1966)
- Drishti IAS: Mithila Cultural Council affiliation
- Telegraph India: Chetna Samiti history (2010)
- The Jharkhand Story / Jharkhand Mirror: Mithila Sanskritik Parishad, Jamshedpur events (2025)

ADDENDUM 4

**Critical Analysis of Award Politics: Sahitya Akademi vs. Videha Parallel Samman**

**Introduction: The Politics of Recognition**

Award systems are never neutral. They are instruments of **cultural legitimation** that determine which artists, which genres, and which voices enter the canon. In India, the Sahitya Akademi (est. 1954), Lalit Kala Akademi (est. 1954), and Sangeet Natak Akademi (est. 1953) constitute the **trinity of state-sponsored cultural recognition**. They operate under the Ministry of Culture, with the President of India appointing the Chairman of the Sangeet Natak Akademi for a five-year term.

Against this state apparatus stands **Videha** (since 2000)—a digital-native, self-funded e-journal that has explicitly declared itself a "parallel Sahitya Akademi," "parallel Lalit Kala Akademi," and "parallel Sangeet Natak Akademi." This is not a claim of equivalence but an act of **institutional dissensus**.

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**Part I: The Sahitya Akademi's Award Architecture for Maithili**

The Sahitya Akademi recognizes **24 languages**, including Maithili (since 1966). Its award categories for each language include:

| Award Category | Established | Prize Amount | Maithili Winners (Selected) |
|---|---|---|---|
| Sahitya Akademi Award (Main) | 1955 | ₹1,00,000 | Yashodhar Jha (1966), Mahendra Malangia (2024) |
| Translation Prize | 1989 | ₹50,000 | Upendranath Jha 'Vyas' (1990), Ratneshwar Mishra (2022) |
| Yuva Puraskar (Under 35) | 2011 | ₹50,000 | |
| Bal Sahitya Puraskar | 2010 | ₹50,000 | Munni Kamat (2025 for *Chukka*) |
| Bhasha Samman | Not specified | Not specified | For contribution to classical/medieval languages |
| Tagore Literature Prize | Not specified | Not specified | For translation of Rabindranath Tagore's works |

**Critical Observation: The "Fellows" Hierarchy**

The Sahitya Akademi also confers **Sahitya Akademi Fellowship**—its highest honor—with only 3-4 living Fellows at any time. Maithili has produced **no Sahitya Akademi Fellow** to date. This absence is conspicuous. The Akademi's Fellowship list is dominated by Hindi, English, and major regional language

writers, revealing a **hierarchical multilingualism** where Maithili remains a "scheduled language" but not a "prestige language."

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**Part II: The Videha Parallel Samman Architecture**

Based on the **Videha_Samman list**, the Videha Parallel Samman operates through three distinct streams:

**1. Parallel Sahitya Akademi Samman (2010-2015)**

| Year | Fellow Award | Main Award | Bal Sahitya | Yuva | Translation |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 2010-11 | Govind Jha | — | — | — | — |
| 2011-12 | Ramanand Renu | Jagdish Prasad Mandal | Mayanath Jha | Anand Kumar Jha | Ramlochan Thakur |
| 2012-13 | Rajnandan Lal Das | Rajdev Mandal | Jagdish Prasad Mandal (again) | Jyoti Sunit Choudhary | Naresh Kumar Vakal |
| 2013-14 | — | Bechan Thakur | Jyoti Sunit Choudhary | Umesh Mandal | — |
| 2014-15 | — | Nand Vilas Rai | Jagdish Prasad Mandal (third time) | Ashish Anchinhar | Shambhu Kumar Singh |

**Critical Observation:** Jagdish Prasad Mandal wins the Bal Sahitya Puraskar **three times** (2012, 2014, and possibly other years). This reveals a **limited pool of recognized writers**—either a sign of Videha's narrow reach or a genuine scarcity of children's literature in Maithili.

**2. Parallel Lalit Kala Akademi Samman (2012-2013)**

The Samman lists a remarkable range of folk artists from rural Mithila (villages like Chajna, Berama, Chanaurganj in Madhubani and Supaul districts):

| Art Form | Awardees (2012) | Awardees (2013) |
|---|---|---|
| Acting (Main) | Shobha Kant Mahato (15), Priyanka Kumari (16), Durganand Thakur (23) | Asha Kumari (18), Md. Samsad Alam, Aparna Kumari (15) |
| Comedy Acting | — | Brahmdeve Paswan, Tatasif Alam |
| Dance | — | Hari Narayan Mandal (58), Sangeeta Kumari (16) |
| Painting | Pankalal Mandal (35), Ramesh Kumar Bharati (23) | Jay Prakash Mandal (35), Chandan Kumar Mandal |
| Harmonium | Parmanand Thakur (30) | Mahadev Saha (58), Jageshwar Prasad Raut (60) |
| Dholak | Bulan Raut (45) | Anup Saday, Kallar Ram (50) |
| Rasnachauki | Bahadur Ram (55) | Vasudev Ram |
| Mridangam | — | Kripal Das (70), |

| Art Form | Awardees (2012) | Awardees (2013) |
|---|---|---|
| | | Khakhar Saday (60) |
| Alha/Mahrai | — | Md. Jibachh (65) |
| Jharni | — | Md. Gul Hasan, Md. Rahman Sahab (58) |
| Nal Vadan | — | Jagat Narayan Mandal (40), Dev Narayan Yadav |
| Folk Song | — | Fudni Devi, Suvita Kumari (18) |
| Khisakar (Storyteller) | — | Chhuthau Ka Yadav (alias Rajkumar), Baijnath Mukhiya |

**Critical Observation:** The age range is striking—from **15-year-old actors** to **80-year-old folk singers** (Jibachh Yadav). This demographic inclusivity is **unmatched by the Sangeet Natak Akademi**, whose awards typically go to established, late-career artists. Videha's parallel academy functions as a **democratic archive**, not merely an award body.

**3. Parallel Sangeet Natak Akademi Samman**

The list includes **Maithili Journalism Samman** (2012: Navendu Kumar Jha) and **Mithila Painting** specialists (Mithilesh Kumari, Veena Devi). These categories exist **nowhere** in the official Sangeet Natak Akademi's framework, which remains rigidly divided into Music, Dance, and Drama.

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**Part III: Comparative Analysis of Award Politics**

| Parameter | Sahitya Akademi (Maithili) | Videha Parallel Samman |
|---|---|---|
| **Funding Source** | Ministry of Culture, Government of India | Self-funded; book sales on Pothi.com |
| **Selection Process** | Advisory Board (5-year terms); opaque | Editor-led; public nomination via Facebook/WhatsApp |
| **Geographic Focus** | Pan-India; diaspora | Rural Mithila (Madhubani, Supaul, Darbhanga) |
| **Genre Coverage** | Published books only | Oral traditions, folk instruments, street theatre |
| **Age Inclusivity** | No age limit; de facto late-career | Explicitly includes minors (15+) and elders (80+) |
| **Transparency** | Minimal; award citations are brief | Hyperlinked PDFs, Facebook announcements, WhatsApp broadcasts |
| **Repeat Awardees** | Rare | Common (Jagdish Prasad Mandal thrice) |
| **Digital Presence** | Static website; PDF lists | Interactive; Google Books; YouTube links |

**Part IV: Theoretical Lenses**

**1. Post-Colonial Critique: The State as Patron**

The Sahitya Akademi represents what Pierre Bourdieu called **state-mediated cultural legitimacy**. By recognizing Maithili in 1966—37 years before its

constitutional status—the state performed an act of **benevolent containment**. It granted literary recognition without political power. The result: Maithili became a "language of culture" but not a "language of administration."

Videha's parallel academies reject this framework entirely. By awarding a 16-year-old Priyanka Kumari from Madhubani for acting, or a 70-year-old Kripal Das for mridangam, Videha asserts that **legitimacy flows from community practice, not state certification**.

**2. Navya-Nyāya Epistemology: What Counts as "Pramana"?**

Navya-Nyāya, the Mithila-originated school of logic (Gangesha Upadhyaya's *Tattvachintamani*), distinguishes between different types of valid cognition (*pramana*):

- **Pratyaksha (Direct Perception):** Videha relies on this. The editor personally verifies artists in their villages. Photos are published. WhatsApp numbers are listed.
- **Shabda (Testimony):** The Sahitya Akademi relies on this. A committee's verbal report determines the award.
- **Anumana (Inference):** The Akademi infers quality from publication history. Videha infers quality from community impact.

Videha's critique of the Sahitya Akademi is fundamentally **epistemological**: the state's *shabda pramana* is corrupted by politics, while Videha's *pratyaksha* is authentic.

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**Part V: Nepal's Alternative Framework**

The Nepali context (referenced in your query) offers another comparison:

| Institution | Type | Maithili Relevance |
|---|---|---|
| Nepal Pragya Pratishthan | State academy (est. 1957) | Includes Maithili as a recognized language |
| Vidyapati Puraskar Kosh | Named award | Directly relevant to Maithili literature |

| Institution | Type | Maithili Relevance |
|---|---|---|
| Phulkumari Mahato Memorial Trust | Private trust | Named after a Maithili woman poet |
| Sajha Puraskar | Public award | Open to all Nepali languages, including Maithili |

**Critical Observation:** Nepal's model **integrates Maithili** within a single national framework (Pragya Pratishthan) rather than creating a separate "parallel" structure. This avoids the legitimacy crisis Videha faces but potentially subjects Maithili to the same state-capture dynamics.

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**Part VI: The Problem of Repeat Awards and Limited Pool**

Videha's award list reveals a **concentration problem**:

- **Jagdish Prasad Mandal** wins the Bal Sahitya Puraskar in 2012 and 2014, plus the Main Award in 2011.
- **Jyoti Sunit Choudhary** wins Bal Sahitya (2013) and Yuva (2012).

This suggests either:

1. **Genuine scarcity** of quality Maithili literature in these categories, or
2. **Network capture**—the same circle of writers nominating each other.

Videha's editorial transparency (public Facebook announcements, WhatsApp lists) mitigates the second possibility but does not eliminate it. The **parallel academy risks replicating the cronyism it critiques**.

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**Part VII: The Digital Divide**

The Sahitya Akademi's recognition of Maithili predates the internet. Its institutional memory is **print-based**—books, physical archives, Delhi-centric meetings.

Videha is **born-digital**. Its awards are announced on Facebook, coordinated via WhatsApp, and archived on Google Books. The PDF itself contains hyperlinks to earlier issues. This **digital nativity** allows Videha to bypass the physical infrastructure of the state academy.

However, the digital divide remains. The 70-year-old Dholak player from Chajna village (Bulan Raut) has no internet presence. Videha's award reaches him only if the editor physically travels to his village—which the evidence suggests they do.

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**Final Verdict**

| Dimension | Sahitya Akademi | Videha Parallel Samman |
|---|---|---|
| **Legitimacy** | State-backed; pan-Indian | Community-backed; Mithila-specific |
| **Inclusivity** | Low (elite, urban, book-focused) | High (rural, oral, folk-focused) |
| **Transparency** | Low | Medium (self-reported) |
| **Financial Support** | Real (₹50,000-1,00,000) | Symbolic (no cash prize stated) |
| **Sustainability** | High (state budget) | Low (editor-dependent) |
| **Epistemological Grounding** | Shabda pramana (testimony) | Pratyaksha pramana (direct perception) |

**Critical Conclusion:** The Sahitya Akademi and Videha's Parallel Samman are **incommensurable institutions**—they operate on different epistemological foundations, serve different constituencies, and distribute different forms of capital (state prestige vs. community recognition).

The Sahitya Akademi remains **necessary** for Maithili's legal and bureaucratic survival. Without its 1966 recognition, Maithili would lack university positions and translation grants.

Videha's Parallel Samman is **necessary** for Maithili's folk and oral traditions. Without it, the 15-year-old actor from Madhubani and the 70-year-old mridangam player from Chajna would remain invisible to the state's recognition machinery.

The ideal solution is not replacement but **coexistence with contestation**—Videha holding the Sahitya Akademi accountable while the Akademi learning from Videha's democratic, transparent, and folk-inclusive practices.

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**Sources:**

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- Sangeet Natak Akademi: Official website (Ministry of Culture)
- Videha Samman (2010-2015 award lists)
- Wikipedia: Sahitya Akademi Award for Maithili
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- The Telegraph India: Chetna Samiti (2010)
- The Jharkhand Story: Mithila Sanskritik Parishad, Jamshedpur (2025)

ADDENDUM 5:

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**On the History of "Sagar Rati Deep Jaray" and the Politics of Maithili Literary Culture**

The history of the *Sagar Rati Deep Jaray* literary gathering movement, as presented by Raman, contains numerous distortions and inaccuracies — from its origins to the present day. Some contributors' roles have been inflated, others diminished, some facts have been altered, and certain individuals have been erased from the record entirely. Although the movement was claimed to be an autonomous body, Raman and Ajit Azad participated on behalf of the Chetna Samiti. Wherever no one else would take up the ceremonial garland (*mala*), they did so as Chetna Samiti representatives — yet in the official record of convenors, the Chetna Samiti's name was replaced by others, in order to construct a particular version of history.

According to Gaurinath's account, after the Chetna Samiti imposed a written ban on Gaurinath, Agnipushp, and Pradeep Bihari, a written apology was demanded from Bihari at the Chetna Samiti's marriage hall venue. Subsequently, he received a Sahitya Akademi award — not for his literary work, but apparently as a reward for this act of submission — and he then became a representative of that very marriage hall establishment. This trio,

joining forces with Shyam Deoghar, carried out actions within *Sagar Rati* that will not be found in Raman's caste-biased version of the history.

As for the register of *Sagar Rati* that Raman claims Vibha Rani lost — whether it was truly lost or allowed to disappear is an open question. But one thing neither Raman nor Vibha Rani knows is that Aarti Kumari sent photostat copies to Umesh Mandal two or three days before her death. She could have sent them to any of the Jha community members, but she did not trust them — and why she did not is a matter worth reflecting on. As they say, blood leaves its mark, blood recognizes the killer.

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**The Darbhanga Gathering and Parallel Politics**

The Darbhanga literary session planned for 31 May 2014, organized by the Darihare-Raman-Bihari group together with the Sahitya Akademi and various bodies recognized by it, would be a sponsored casteist event — the second such gathering (after Delhi) that they would also claim as the 83rd session. A story reading of works like *Raar Ke Sukh Balay* ("Pleasure in Others' Misfortune") was to be held there. The Mehath session, by contrast, had barred casteist Brahmanist-Kayasthist figures like Raman, Darihare, and Bihari.

It is often said that *Sagar Rati Deep Jaray* functions like a training school for new fiction writers. But what is the truth? Is its character any different from the Sahitya Akademi's? Was it not subject to the same factional maneuvering as the Akademi?

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**The 79th Session and the Politics of Capture**

The boycott of the 79th session by Hirendra Jha and others, and Raman's casteist declarations there against Umesh Paswan, constituted not an opposition to Maithili but a political attempt at capture. This politics of capture had begun even before the 79th session. At the 74th session in Hazaribagh, Pradeep Bihari proposed taking up the garland — but only in order to block another's proposal. He subsequently withdrew his own proposal in favor of his faction. He repeated this maneuver at the 75th session. Whether he was being used as an instrument of this blackmail operation, or was himself its principal actor, is a reasonable question. His creative writing lacks vitality, but his petty politics does not. The Sahitya Akademi award he received was obtained by groveling and seeking forgiveness from the Chetna Samiti — taken shamelessly. He understands that focusing on quality writing is foolish, since prizes do not come from merit in

this system; Sahitya Akademi recognition requires political maneuvering, and at that he is a master. Maithili literature be damned.

### The Net Result: Discouragement, Not Development

In this environment, new writers were not trained; on the contrary, more people were driven away from Maithili literature than were brought into it. The net result was negative.

The boycott politics affected sessions at Supaul, Deoghar, and Narhan. Under the politics of capture, when the Kathmandu session was organized, Dhirendra Premrishi ensured that no local Nepali Maithili writers were even informed it was happening — as reported by Manoj Mukti.

Ashok Avichal, Shyam Darihare, and Raman blackmailed the Deoghar organizer Om Prakash Jha, threatening to boycott unless the Sahitya Akademi's session was given official recognition as a *Sagar Rati* gathering. But Aarti Kumari's death had created a first real opportunity to call the blackmailers' bluff. The session proceeded with unprecedented success — the blackmailers' boycott only strengthened it.

### Deoghar as a True Training Ground

The Deoghar session proved to be a genuine training ground — one from which Raman, Darihare, and Bihari could have learned something about literary quality, had they attended. But they are pragmatists: they know that prizes are won through networking, not quality. Avichal has no talent whatsoever; no training could help him, and he was wise to save his time by staying away.

If quality were to become the standard in *Sagar Rati*, who would notice mediocre figures like Bihari, Darihare, and Raman? So instead they will hold their own Sahitya Akademi sessions training Brahmin youth in how to write casteist stories. Very well — this will at least keep fools out of *Sagar Rati*, and for that, paradoxically, Maithili literature should be grateful to them.

### On Language and Caste

In Maithili, Brahmanist cultural manipulation has been extensive. The word *raar* (loosely, "outsider" or "low-caste") in the Brahmin worldview encompasses Bhumihars, Rajputs, Kayasthas, and all non-Brahmin castes. Even folk proverbs have been rigged: the saying "ten Brahmins, ten stomachs;

ten *raar*, one stomach" — implying Brahmin individualism and non-Brahmin unity — is reversed in non-Brahmin oral tradition: "ten *raar*, ten stomachs; ten Brahmins, one stomach." But mediocre figures like Bihari do not grasp this.

The story *Raar Ke Sukh Balay*, which Raman, Darihare, and Bihari have written about Jagdish Prasad Mandal, is not merely an insult to him — given Darihare and Raman's own definition of *raar*, it is an insult to every non-Brahmin in Mithila.

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**Brahmanist Censorship at Work**

At the Rahuwa Sangram session, everyone including Raman resolved to stay awake all night. But after dinner, when the "celebrated" writers had read and gone to sleep, it was the young writers' turn in the early morning hours. When Ashish Anchinhar came to read his story, the moderator was dozing and only the session chair Shivshankar Shrinivas was awake — Raman, who had proposed the all-night vigil, was snoring. In protest, and despite the chair's encouragement, Anchinhar refused to read. His post-modern story was later published in *Videha Laghu Katha*.

Brahmanist censorship is so powerful that neither organizer, nor Raman, nor the chair's account in the fabricated official history of *Sagar Rati* will contain any mention of this incident. The Brahmanist instinct to conceal inconvenient facts is the reason.

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**The Question of Eighty-One Sessions**

People ask whether all 81 sessions of *Sagar Rati* actually took place. In earlier times, manuscripts were submitted by post, and the "celebrated" works were read aloud — young writers who physically attended were pushed to the bottom, or given the slot when people were asleep. When Munna-ji protested, he was told to keep quiet; the absent were also marked present in the register. Many sessions had fewer than ten actual participants, but the attendance register showed far more — some never came at all, some sent work by post, and some signed in and disappeared. Just as fewer than three thousand casualties does not constitute a battle, fewer than ten participants cannot constitute a proper *Sagar Rati*. The count of 81 shrinks considerably under scrutiny.

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**On Videha's Stance**

Many people over the past six years have commented that Videha has changed and become like the establishment it opposed. Videha's mission has not changed and will not change. If some people joined Videha for self-interest but could not shed their inherited caste-superiority complex — and used emotional blackmail, threats, abusive emails and phone calls, and threats to walk out (significantly, all those who threatened to walk out have so far been Brahmins who wanted only symbolic protest, not real change) — then the answer is that truth can be used or misused. Those who now feel Videha has changed were those who wanted only symbolic resistance all along. That is itself the essence of Brahmanist thinking.

Videha will continue exactly as it has for the past six years, and Maithili literature will continue on this path for at least the next thirty years. Whatever merit a person has — regardless of caste, religion, or region — that is how far they will advance through Videha.

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**Final Note: The Convergence of Opponents**

Those who abused Suman and Amar in Yatri's name, and those who abused Yatri in Suman-Amar's name, have now all united behind Darihare, Raman, and Bihari to fight a final battle against Videha — all in the name of preserving Brahmanist dominance in Maithili literature.

Although there had been issues with Sagar Raati for a long time—including the problematic trend of writers simply reading their own stories and then going to sleep—no one had protested against it. In the year 2008, at Rahua Sangram, under the coordination of Ashok Avichal, Ashish Anachinhar protested this practice; despite being present there, he refused to read his story.

In the year 2012, Sagar Raati was "hijacked" by the Sahitya Akademi in Delhi, where the same issue of authors reading their stories and falling asleep recurred. This was reported by Ashish Anachinhar, and the report is available on Videha as well as other social media platforms.

The End of "Sagar Raati Deep Jarey" and the Rise of the Sahitya Akademi Storytelling Session (Report by Ashish Anchinhar)

On July 21, 2007, in Saharsa, Jivakant Ji indicated that Maithili had been afflicted with a "royal disease" at "Sagar Raati Deep Jarey." Following that,

Ramanand Jha Raman urged writers to save Maithili from this royal disease. But as far as I know, this merely became a parrot-like repetition. Because this royal disease, right before the eyes of Jivakant Ji and Raman Ji, gradually laid Maithili low. The malignant form of this disease of Maithili became even more apparent when, on the soil of Delhi, "Mailorong" – acting as a pawn of the Sahitya Akademi – staged "Sagar Raati Deep Jarey" and killed the Maithili language.

On the evening of March 24, 2012, people were under the illusion that "Sagar Raati Deep Jarey" was being organized in Delhi. The coordinator, Devshankar Navin, was supposed to have taken the lead, but then Agana Prakash and Mailorong appeared from somewhere, and the result was that later it was discovered that it wasn't Sagar Raati at all; it was merely a storytelling session organized by Mailorong with the Sahitya Akademi's money. Mailorong intended to present it as the 76th "Sagar Raati Deep Jarey," but since "Sagar Raati Deep Jarey" has no provision to receive funds from government literary institutions, the sequence of the 76th "Sagar Raati Deep Jarey" was broken, and thus it could not be recognized as the 76th. The fact that it was backed by the Sahitya Akademi's money was clearly visible in the photos, where the name "Sahitya Akademi" appeared as a sponsor. Devendra Kumar Devesh had come as the Akademi's observer. The literary world is condemning the Sahitya Akademi's attempt to break this sole independent gathering of Maithili. However, let me make it clear that even Ramanand Jha Raman, who spoke of removing the royal disease, witnessed this heinous act with his own eyes and gave his silent consent. Now, since this was not "Sagar Raati Deep Jarey," I will henceforth analyze it only as a storytelling session.

Because people were misled into believing this was "Sagar Raati Deep Jarey," a book stall by Videha was set up at the venue. But at that very moment, Prakash Jha, the organizer of "Mailorong," prohibited it. Prakash Ji said that a stall would only be possible if books were distributed for free. However, his suggestion was rejected by the stall manager, Ashish Chaudhary. In protest, Gajendra Thakur, the editor of Videha, left the venue. Initially, I had announced on Facebook that I would present a ghazal and haiku poster exhibition at Sagar Raati, but since it wasn't Sagar Raati after all, where could we do it, especially after the opposition to the Videha book stall? We protested and decided to postpone the poster exhibition. The storytelling session began with the release of twelve books, including five in Hindi-Urdu and seven in Maithili.

This storytelling session was divided into eight sessions. The chairperson was Gangesh Gunjan, and the host was Ajit Kumar Azad.

In the first session of the Sahitya Akademi's storytelling session, stories by Vibhuti Anand ("Chahari"), Menaka Mallik ("Malaham"), and Praveen Bharadwaj ("Purukharakh") were read. Ashok Mehta and Ramanand Jha Raman reviewed the stories. Ashok Mehta said that the use of certain words in Vibhuti Anand's story was jarring. Regarding Menaka Mallik's language, he noted that despite living in Begusarai for so long, her language still retained the flavor of Darbhanga and Madhubani. Regarding Praveen Bharadwaj's story, he said that since the author was new, his story was good by that standard.

Ramanand Jha Raman expressed concern over the abundance of Hindi words in Vibhuti Anand's story. Regarding Menaka Mallik's story, he said that women's writing has advanced. He called the language of Praveen Bharadwaj's story "essay-like" and expressed hope that his language would improve over time.

Then came the audience's turn. Saumya Jha found Vibhuti Anand's story incomplete and disconnected from its setting, but she said she liked it despite its flaws. Devshankar Navin jumped in to defend Vibhuti Anand (!!!), but Saumya Jha stood her ground. Ashish Anchinhar asked Vibhuti Anand the meaning of a technical term in his story, "abhadra miss call" (indecent missed call). Then, Devshankar Navin spent 20 minutes defending Vibhuti Anand with irrelevant facts from a story by Rajkamal (!!!), and ultimately, Vibhuti Anand did not answer the audience's question.

In the second session, stories by Vibha Rani ("Sapanke Nai Bharmaau"), Vineet Utpal ("Nimantran"), and Dukhmochhan Jha ("Chhutait Sanskara") were read. Reviewing Vibha Rani's story, Malangiya called it a bold story. Sarang Kumar suggested shortening the narration. Kamal Kant Jha called it unnatural, saying a mother cannot disregard her son, but Shridharam argued that if the son's character changes, the mother's character can also change. Kamal Mohan Chunnu said the story had been published in Ghar Bahar. The organizer announced that Vibha Rani's story "Sapanke Nai Bharmaau" was being excluded from the session.

Regarding Vineet Utpal's story "Nimantran," Malangiya felt it was a love story appropriate for the characters' ages. Sarang Kumar called it a metropolitan story but said its structure needed strengthening. Shridharam saw the author's honesty in the story but emphasized the need for rewriting. Harendra was reminded of a story by Gulshan Nanda, but Pradeep Bihari disagreed with Harendra's rambling, calling it a story of today and tomorrow. Regarding Dukhmochhan Jha's "Chhutait Sanskara," Malangiya remained silent, saying he hadn't heard it. Sarang Kumar called it a sketch. Kamal Kant Jha found it a "cultured" story. Shridharam liked the beginning but not the end. Shubhendu Shekhar sensed a generation gap, and Kamal Mohan Chunnu found it a travelogue. Audience participation in the second session was almost nil.

After the second session, there was a meal. The meal included rice, lentil soup, vegetables, bhujia, papad, yogurt, and overly sweet rasgullas. After the meal came "Zero Hour" – meaning, eat your meal and reduce the storytelling venue to zero. But most people remained, though some, like Vibhuti Anand, dissolved into the void. During Zero Hour, Harendra Kumar Jha raised the topic of developing children's literature in Maithili. He stressed that children's literature should be distributed for free. Some insisted that in any future Sagar Raati, at least one session should be devoted entirely to children's stories. Surprisingly, Devshankar Navin, who is familiar with online activities, forgot about children's literature available via Videha on the internet. On that note, Ashish Anchinhar explained the free download process to Harendra Ji. But predictably, children's literature readily available online was deliberately undermined. When the discussion turned to writing children's literature in every genre, Ashish Anchinhar proposed the concept of "children's ghazals" in Maithili for the first time. However, interestingly, the discussion on children's literature got stuck on the topic of awards. Some expressed sadness that it was starting now when their time had passed. Others lamented that someone was preoccupied with naming something after their daughter. During this debate, Avinash Ji insisted that just as there is "children's story," there should also be "adult story." Since he is well-known to those who have participated in Patna's Sagar Raati, expectations are high. Dhanakar Ji's colorful report has appeared in several places (including Videha Facebook and Ghar Bahar).

After Zero Hour, the third session began – purely based on vihani (flash fiction). In this session, Munna Ji Chashma read three vihani stories titled "Sevak" (Servant) and "Kattarpanthi" (Fundamentalist). Arvind Thakur read two vihani stories – "Daam" (Price) and "Agam-Agochar" (Inaccessible/Imperceptible). Pradeep Bihari read a vihani story titled "Budi" (Old Woman). The main point of this session was that Munna Ji insisted on calling them vihani katha rather than short stories, but Ashok Mehta countered that "short story" was the correct term. In this session, Munna Ji insisted that one Sagar Raati event should be dedicated to vihani katha.

From the audience, Ashish Anchinhar called Munna Ji's vihani story "Chashma" (Glasses) a story that exposes the fake sensibility growing in modern life. Earlier, Devshankar Navin Ji had highlighted the growing insensitivity in society in his speech. Anchinhar also drew Navin Ji's attention to this aspect of sensibility. Many comments came on these vihani stories, mostly in the format of "liked it," "very good," etc.

In the fourth session, Harendra Kumar Jha's long story "Ekta Chhal Gaam" (There Was a Village) and Pankaj Satyam's story "Ekta Vikshiptak Chithi" (A Letter from a Deranged Person) were presented. On "Ekta Chhal Gaam," Chunnu Ji said the story was too sentimental but the theme was good. Shridharam Ji agreed with Chunnu Ji's criticism. Chunnu Ji also said that the concern for the village was well expressed. Shridharam Ji said it would have been better if Dalit assertion was also present in this story. From the audience, Ashish Anchinhar told Kamal Mohan Chunnu Ji that either he hasn't read Jagdish Prasad Mandal's stories or has forgotten them. If Chunnu Ji sees the concern for the village in Harendra Ji's story the same way it appears in Jagdish Mandal Ji's stories, he could have offered a better critique. In response to my point, a staunch Brahminical member of the organizing team said, "You give an example of Jagdish Mandal Ji's story, I was ready to give one too," but the host stopped that Brahminical member from arguing. Other critics in this session included Pradeep Bihari, Avinash, and Raman Kumar Singh.

In the fifth session, Dinbandhu Ji's story "Aparadhi" (Criminal), Vinaymohan Jagdish Ji's "Sankalpka Bal" (Power of Resolve), and Ashish Anchinhar's "Katal Katha" (Cut Story) were read. On Ashish Anchinhar's story, Chunnu Ji said it was a failure in terms of craft, and that it was unclear what was being

said, confusing the reader. Elaborating on this, Kamlesh Kishor Jha said the story lacked a central point. Mukesh Jha said that no one had appointed Anchinhar Ji as a doctor and told him to write stories. Similarly, Ashish Jha (husband of Kumud Singh) said, "I understood half of it, didn't understand half – the report doesn't clarify whether it was the story or not." On Vinaymohan Jagdish Ji's story, Chunnu Ji said it was too sentimental. These people also criticized Dinbandhu Ji's story, but in a superficial manner.

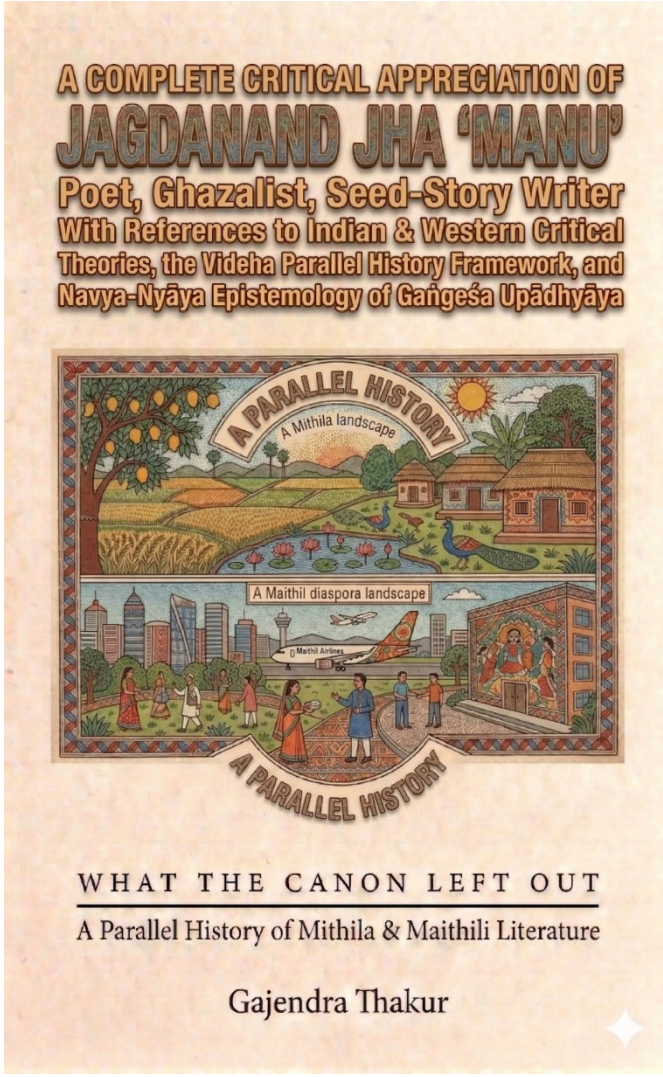
In the sixth session, Kashyap Kamal Ji's long story "Vote" and Kamlesh Kishor Jha's "Gudariya" (Ragged Doll) were read. Kaushal Jha's story "Nyay" (Justice) was on the list, but he was not present at the time of reading. Regarding "Bhot," Munna Ji said the story awakened those who were lulled by laughter. Kamlesh Ji's story was also good, but again, superficial criticism.

In the seventh session, Ashok Kumar Mehta's "Bite," Kamal Kant Jha's "Viddati," and Mahendra Malangiya Ji's story "Lunch" (read by Prakash Jha) were presented. Harendra Jha considered Mehta Ji's story weakly constructed. Kamal Kant Ji's story was praised for its beautiful descriptive quality, especially the bus-related episode. Malangiya Ji's story was deemed good, but with a weak ending. Chunnu Ji found the construction of "Bite" weak and considered the stories of Kamal Kant and Malangiya Ji to have criminal backgrounds.

The eighth session concluded with the chairperson's speech and a short, untitled oral story.

After all this, the search began for the coordinator of the next Sagar Raati (who knows if it will be another storytelling session). The first proposal was for Arvind Thakur (Supaul), the second for Vibha Rani (Chennai), and the third from Delhi was for Bhavesh Nandan. Opinions were sought from everyone. Many favored Chennai. Ultimately, the 76th "Sagar Raati Deep Jarey" got a female coordinator in the form of Vibha Rani.

**LESSON 029 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**



# A COMPLETE CRITICAL APPRECIATION OF

# JAGDANAND JHA 'MANU'

Poet · Ghazalist · Seed-Story Writer

*With References to Indian & Western Critical Theories,*
*the Videha Parallel History Framework,*
*and Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya*

## Abstract

Jagdanand Jha 'Manu' is one of the most versatile and prolific voices in the contemporary Maithili parallel literary tradition. A poet, ghazalist, and seed-story (bīhani kathā) writer, he has published multiple collections across three genres: the poetry and song anthology Vyathā (2025, Pallavi Prakashan; ISBN 978-93-48865-53-3), the ghazal collection Naḍhiyā Bhukaiye Hamar Ghaṛārīpar (1st ed. 2022, 2nd ed. 2023; ISBN 978-93-93135-18-6), the seed-story anthology Tohār Katek Raṅg (2022; ISBN 978-93-93135-29-2), and children's stories in the Videha Shishu Utsav series ('Chonhā', Shishu Utsav 51–100). His literary formation began through the Videha digital platform (2010) and was shaped by the Anchinhar Ākhara movement, which restored formal prosodic rigour to the Maithili ghazal after a 'dark interlude' of grammatically incorrect practice. This critical appreciation applies Indian classical theories (Rasa, Dhvani, Vakrokti, Alamkāra), Western frameworks (Formalism, Marxism, New Criticism, Postcolonialism, Gender Theory, Ecocriticism), the Videha Parallel History Framework, and the epistemological techniques of Navya-Nyāya logician Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya to assess Manu's literary corpus. The study argues that Manu exemplifies the digital-democratic strand of Maithili parallel literature: a writer who came to letters as a migrant labourer from rural Mithila, without institutional literary education, using the digital-

first infrastructure of the Videha movement to develop a technically rigorous yet emotionally immediate literary voice rooted in the pain of displacement, the love of mother-soil, and the struggle for dignity.

# I. Biographical and Contextual Introduction

## 1.1 Life, Origins, and the Migrant Condition

Jagdanand Jha 'Manu' was born into a Maithili-speaking family of rural Bihar. His pen name 'Manu' — chosen in homage to the primordial lawgiver and simultaneously a name of domestic tenderness in Maithili — signals a creative self-construction: the writer fashioning an identity between the universal and the intimate. His email address (jagdanandjha@gmail.com) and mobile/WhatsApp contact (+91 9212-46-1006) — published in his books — reflect the Videha movement's ethic of accessibility: the author is not a remote institutional figure but a communicating presence.

The biographical fact that overshadows all of Manu's writing is the experience of migration. He is, by his own repeated testimony, a pardeshī — an outsider in the urban centres of Delhi, Mumbai — who has left his Maithili village for economic survival, yet remains spiritually and aesthetically bound to the 'māṭi-pānī' (soil and water) of Mithila. This condition — the internal migrant who earns his bread in a metropolis while his heart remains tethered to Madhubani fields, to the fragrance of mahuā blossoms, to his grandmother's house, to the Chhath festival by the pond — is the lived experience from which all his literary production flows.

In the prefatory note to Naḍhiyā Bhukaiye Hamar Ghaṛārīpar, Manu writes with disarming honesty: 'I have no great knowledge, no literary education in any formal sense. My Maithili was weak when I began; it remains imperfect. But what I have is the love of this soil.' He credits his literary birth to Gajendra Thakur, who connected him to the Videha Facebook group around 2010, and his formal ghazal training to mentor Ashish Anchinhar, who guided him from 2011 onwards through the Anchinhar Ākhara movement. The dedication of Vyathā to his late 'Dādā Bābā' Dr. Kamalakant Jha — described as 'the source of my literary inspiration' — reveals a family inheritance of scholarly culture even within economic constraint.

## 1.2 The Videha and Anchinhar Ākhara Formations

Manu's literary career is inseparable from two institutional formations: the Videha eJournal (videha.co.in, ISSN 2229-547X) — the first Maithili fortnightly e-journal, founded by Gajendra Thakur — and the Anchinhar Ākhara movement, launched April 11, 2008, which restored formal prosodic standards to the Maithili ghazal through the Ghajalsastram (the first comprehensive Maithili-language theoretical account of ghazal prosody).

The Videha Parallel History Framework (Parts 1–35+, videha.co.in/gajenthakur.htm) positions the Anchinhar Ākhara movement as a correction of what it calls the 'dark interlude' of Maithili ghazal-writing — a period in which grammatically incorrect ghazals (violating bahra and qāfiyā norms) came to dominate, and technically correct practitioners like Vijaynath Jha and Yoganand Heera were erased from literary history. Ashish Anchinhar published Maithili Ghazalak Vyākaraṇa o Itihāsa (Grammar and History of Maithili Ghazal), providing the systematic theoretical framework through which Manu and 350–400 other previously marginalised writers entered the literary mainstream within a single decade.

The digital-first strategy of the Anchinhar movement — blog, Wikipedia, online mushaira — is directly implicated in Manu's trajectory: he is a product of digital democratisation. He would not have become a published literary figure without the blog, the Facebook group, the online mushaira circuit. This makes him emblematic of what the Parallel History calls the 'Videha Era: The Digital Era 2000–Present' — the transformation of Maithili literature through internet access, which bypassed the caste-based institutional gatekeeping of the Sahitya Akademi apparatus.

## 1.3 Publisher and Institutional Location

Manu publishes exclusively through Pallavi Prakashan, Nirmali, Supaul — the same press that publishes Nand Vilas Roy and other writers of the democratic-parallel tradition. Dr. Umesh Mandal, who manages Pallavi Prakashan, also handled the typography and page-setting of all Manu's books. The Nirmali connection is not accidental: Nirmali (Supaul district) is a small Bihar town that has become a publishing hub for the Maithili parallel tradition precisely because it lies outside the Delhi-Darbhanga establishment axis.

# II. The Corpus: Works, Forms, and Publication History

## 2.1 Vyathā: Poetry and Song Anthology (2025)

Vyathā (व्यथा — 'Anguish' or 'Pain') is Manu's most substantial single-volume literary achievement to date. Published by Pallavi Prakashan in 2025 (ISBN 978-93-48865-53-3; price ₹290), it contains 34 poems (kavitā) and 16 songs (gīt). Cover art is by Smt. Aparna Sarkar, Noida. The preface by Dr. Ram Ashish Singh (former principal, H.P.S. College, Nirmali; Veer Kunwar Singh University, Madhepura) provides a scholarly introduction situating Manu's poetics.

The table of contents reveals the collection's thematic architecture in two parts. Part 1 (kavitā, poems 1–34) opens with 14 poems on Mithila — its glories, its decline, the grief of separation — and then moves through poems on women ('Ham Nārī Nahi' — 'I am Not a Woman' [the ironic inversion], 'Konā Madar Day Happy'), consciousness ('Monak Vyathā'), maternity ('Māe'), the poet's vocation ('Hami Kavi Nahi Chhi'), economic conditions ('Pāi' — 'Money'), mortality ('Ek Din Hami Marab'), and political satire ('Dūlhā Ājuken' — 'Today's Groom', 'Ghaṭakak Jawāb' — 'The Matchmaker's Answer', 'Rojgār Banāo Kavitā' — 'Make Employment, Poetry'). Part 2 contains 16 songs (gīt) including devotional compositions for the Chhath festival ('Bhola Bābāk Gīt', 'Māiyāk Gīt').

The preface frames Manu's poetics through Wordsworth's definition of poetry as 'the spontaneous overflow of powerful feelings' — a significant choice that positions him within a Romantic-realist synthesis. Dr. Singh's phrase 'yathārthavādī kavitā' (realist poetry) for Manu's dominant mode is accurate, though the collection also contains strongly imaginative-devotional passages in the gīt section.

## 2.2 Naḍhiyā Bhukaiye Hamar Ghaṛārīpar: Maithili Ghazal Collection

Naḍhiyā Bhukaiye Hamar Ghaṛārīpar ('The Dog Barks at My Homestead') is Manu's landmark contribution to the Maithili ghazal tradition. First published 2022, second edition 2023 (ISBN 978-93-93135-18-6; price ₹200), it was edited in e-book form as early as 2014 before its print appearance. The collection contains 101 ghazals organised by prosodic form (bahra): ghazals 1–

36 in Saral Vārṇik Bahra (simple syllabic metre), ghazals 37–47 in equal syllabic verse, ghazals 48–50 in Bahra-e-Mutaqārib, 51–56 in Bahra-e-Ramal, 57–58 in Bahra-e-Rajaz, 59–60 in Bahra-e-Hazaj, 61–62 in Bahra-e-Mushākil, 63 in Bahra-e-Asam, 64–65 in Bahra-e-Khafūk, 66 in Bahra-e-Jadīd, 67–79 in Bahra-e-Kalīb, 70–71 in Bahra-e-Kabīr, 72 in Bahra-e-Hamīd, 73 in Bahra-e-Mujassam or Mujās, 74–75 Hazal, 76–88 Bāl Ghazal (children's ghazals), and 89–101 Bhakti Ghazal (devotional ghazals). This organisation by bahra is itself a pedagogical and political statement: it demonstrates mastery of the prosodic range and teaches the forms to readers.

The dedication — to all those who 'keep the rebellion of their homeland soil alive in their hearts despite being far from it' — encapsulates the collection's dominant affect. The title poem (Ghazal 4) uses the village dog's barking at an empty homestead as the central image of the abandoned Maithili home: the dog, guardian of the hearth, now barks at a vacant house whose owner has left for the city.

## 2.3 Tohār Katek Raṅg: Seed Stories (Bīhani Kathā) Collection

Tohār Katek Raṅg ('How Many Colours Are Yours?') is Manu's collection of Maithili bīhani kathā (seed stories), published in 2022 (ISBN 978-93-93135-29-2; price ₹200). As a bīhani kathā collection, it situates Manu within the genre that the Videha Parallel History (Part 32) identifies as 'a micronarrative form unique to Maithili literature': the seed story is 'not simply a compressed short story but a genetically distinct form' characterised by 'seed logic — an ending that opens rather than closes meaning.' The title — 'How Many Colours Are Yours?' — gestures toward the multifaceted nature of human experience, identity, and relationship that the seed stories explore.

## 2.4 Children's Fiction: 'Chonhā' (Videha Shishu Utsav)

Manu's 'Chonhā' ('Anxiety/Restlessness') appears in the Videha Maithili Shishu Utsav anthology (numbers 51–100), demonstrating his range across adult literary forms and children's fiction. 'Chonhā' narrates the story of Sanjay — a boy of about ten afflicted with debilitating sun-induced migraine headaches that are systematically ignored by his parents, dismissed as pretexts for avoiding work. The story documents, with scrupulous attention to the child's subjective experience of pain, the failure of the adult world's care structures — parental inattention, inadequate medical access — while simultaneously capturing the texture of rural-to-urban migration (the family's move from a Bihar village to Delhi) and the experience of disability among children in

marginalised families. The narrative is remarkable for its empathetic penetration of a child's consciousness and its quiet, devastating critique of parental neglect.

# III. Thematic Analysis

## 3.1 Pardesh and Māṭī-Pānī: The Poetics of Displacement

The single most pervasive theme in Manu's entire corpus is what might be called the poetics of pardesh — the experience of being in a foreign place (Delhi, Mumbai) while belonging, body and soul, to Mithila. Every major work returns to this axis: the ghazal collection is dedicated to those who keep 'the rebellion of their homeland soil alive'; the poems of Vyathā obsessively circle the sensory memory of Mithila (the fragrance of mahuā, the dripping roof in monsoon, the grandmother's hand, the sound of cowbells, the taste of grandmother's khichari-kachri). In ghazal after ghazal, the refrain is departure, separation, and the longing for return.

The title poem of the ghazal collection — 'Naḍhiyā Bhukaiye Hamar Ghaṛārīpar' — makes this displacement concrete through the figure of the barking dog: 'The dog barks at my homestead / The cur sleeps at my doorstep / I abandoned my village to come here / Living on monthly debt to feed my belly / What I earned breaking my hands and feet / Was spent by evening on cheap liquor / I saved a whole year cutting corners / And it all went on the return fare.' This is not romantic pastoral nostalgia but economic biography: migration as compelled by poverty, sustained by debt, the body's labour consumed by the city's appetite.

The philosophical category operative here is what Henri Lefebvre (following Marx) calls 'alienation from place' — the worker's separation from the conditions of production (the land, the community, the cultural framework) that constitute their being. Manu's poetry is the literature of this alienation, experienced not abstractly but sensorially: the smell of mahuā, the sound of the Chhath festival, the taste of grandmother's food — these are the sensory markers of the unalienated life that the migrant worker carries in memory as compensation for the alienated present.

## 3.2 Mithilā Rāj: The Political Poem

A substantial cluster of poems in Vyathā engages directly with the demand for a separate Mithila state — 'Hamrā Mithilā Rāj Chāhī' ('We Want Mithila State'). These poems are the most overtly political in Manu's corpus. 'Hami Mithilāputra / Duniyāme Sabhase Āgū Āgū Chhi' ('We are Maithili sons / We lead the world') celebrates the intellectual achievements of Mithila — Āryabhaṭa, Chāṇakya, Vidyāpati, Mandanmiśra, Darbhanga Mahārāja — as evidence of a heritage that demands political recognition. The poem 'Hamrā Mithilā Rāj Chāhī' (Poem 10) argues: 'Bhīkh Nahi Adhikār Chāhī / Hamrā Mithilā Rāj Chāhī / Je Hamrā Achi Khūnme / O Khūnak Adhikār Chāhī' — 'We want rights, not charity / We want Mithila State / What is in our blood / We want the right of that blood.'

In formal critical terms, these are poems of the public sphere — what Habermas would call Öffentlichkeit — asserting a collective identity and political claim. They represent the genre of agon: the adversarial poem that positions itself against a political order (the Bihar-India administrative structure that denies Mithila statehood) and demands redress. Within the Videha Parallel History framework, the Mithila state demand is understood as the democratic extension of the parallel tradition's resistance to Brahminical-establishment Maithili: if the language and culture cannot be protected within existing Bihar, a separate state is the political corollary.

## 3.3 Women: Anguish, Strength, and the Satirical Inversion

Vyathā contains four poems specifically addressing women's condition: 'Hami Nārī Nahi' ('I Am Not a Woman' — a poem of female defiance), 'Konā Madar Day Happy' ('When Mother Is Not Happy'), 'Māe' ('Mother'), and 'Ke Patiyāet' ('Who Would Believe It?'). Together these constitute Manu's feminist suite, ranging from the celebration of maternal devotion (Māe) to the satirical skewering of modern children's indifference to mothers (Konā Madar Day Happy) to the acute portrait of the woman who suffers in silence, perpetually judged ('Ke Patiyāet Ai Kekarā Kahū / Sabhak Ānkhime Pasi Kaer Konā Rahū / Sadikhan Āngur Hamre Par Uṭhal / Katek Parīkṣā Āmo Sahū' — 'Who would believe it, to whom should I say / How do I live, always under the eyes of all / Fingers always pointing at me / How many more tests must I endure?').

The poem 'Konā Madar Day Happy' is remarkable for its code-switching: the phrase 'Mother's Day Happy' enters the Maithili verse as a marker of urban-English modernity that has displaced the authentic relationship between children and mothers. The satirical frame — if Mother is not happy then how

can Mother's Day be happy? — cuts across the commodification of maternal sentiment that social media 'Mother's Day' culture represents. This is Bakhtinian heteroglossia in poetic form: the English marketing phrase is placed inside the Maithili poem precisely to defamiliarise it, to reveal its vacuity.

## 3.4 Economic Conditions: Money, Unemployment, and Political Satire

Poems titled 'Pāi' ('Money', two versions), 'Rojgār Banāo Kavitā' ('Make Employment, Poetry'), 'Ānhār' ('Darkness'), and multiple ghazals address the economic devastation of rural Mithila directly. Ghazal 11 of Naḍhiyā begins: 'Hamar Kamāi Kon Konāme Paral Achi / Mantrī Ghārame Baimānīk Sonā Garal Achi' — 'My earnings are lying in some corner / The minister's house has corrupt gold settled in it.' Ghazal 15: 'Bhraṣṭāchārken Ṭhekā Ājuk Sarkār Lene / Kārī Rupayāk Karamān Dharmācār Lene' — 'Today's government has taken the contract for corruption / Carrying the accounts of black money as religious practice.' Ghazal 10: 'Bujhalak Netā Ai Janatā Pākal Achi / Ām Janatā Tañ Sadikhan Bhāgal Achi' — 'The leader has understood the people are ripe / The common people are always on the run.'

These political ghazals are the formal equivalent of what Raymond Williams calls 'structures of feeling' — the lived texture of political corruption and economic exclusion experienced at the level of ordinary rural life. They are not abstract political tracts but embodied social poems: the empty village, the young men fled to cities, the drunk men in the village square, the women weeping for absent husbands, the politician who feeds on public misery.

## 3.5 Childhood and Disability: 'Chonhā'

The story 'Chonhā' is Manu's most narratively ambitious work and deserves extended consideration. A boy named Sanjay suffers from what is clearly photosensitive migraine — a condition that intensifies with sunlight and diminishes as day ends. This medical condition is rendered with clinical accuracy from the inside: the reader experiences the throbbing headache, the fear of sunlight, the blurred vision, the inability to see a ball in play (indicating also probable severe myopia). The story's social analysis is acute: Sanjay's illness is dismissed by his parents as 'excuse-making', his grandmother offers a teaspoon of oil (folk remedy), his uncle gives generic headache tablets. Only when Sanjay notices in class that he cannot read the blackboard does the narrative pivot toward the partial recognition of his visual impairment — and even then, no proper medical consultation follows.

The story is simultaneously a meditation on child neglect in migrant families (Sanjay's father is working in Delhi; the move to Delhi brings Sanjay's condition to crisis), on the inadequacy of rural healthcare infrastructure, and on the particular suffering of the intelligent, sensitive child who is academically brilliant (top of his class) but physically compromised and emotionally invisible to his caregivers. Manu's empathy for child consciousness here anticipates what child development scholars call 'children's epistemic agency' — the capacity of children to know and experience what adults cannot or will not recognise.

# IV. Formal and Structural Analysis

## 4.1 The Maithili Ghazal: Form, Tradition, and Manu's Practice

The ghazal is among the most formally constrained poetic forms in world literature. As documented in the Videha Parallel History (Part 4: 'The Revitalization of Maithili Ghazal: The Anchinhar Ākhara Movement'), the ghazal's formal architecture requires: the matla (opening sher in which both hemistiches carry qāfiyā and radīf); the consistent qāfiyā (mono-rhyme) in the second hemistich of every sher; the radīf (identical refrain word or phrase) following each qāfiyā; the independently self-contained sher as the fundamental compositional unit; the takhallus (pen name) in the maqta (concluding sher); and adherence to a consistent bahra (metre) throughout. The Arabic-Persian formal heritage — from the ghazal's emergence as the amorous prelude (nasīb) of the qasīda through the Persian masters Rumi, Hafiz, Sa'di, to the Urdu tradition of Mir, Ghalib, Iqbal — reaches Maithili through a lineage documented by the Anchinhar movement from Pandit Jivan Jha through Kāvīvara Sitarām Jha, Kashikant Mishra 'Madhup', Vijaynath Jha, and Yoganand Heera.

Manu's ghazal practice is formally rigorous. His organisation of Naḍhiyā Bhukaiye by bahra — with 66 ghazals in various Arabic-Persian metres — demonstrates systematic mastery of prosodic range. The dominant bahra in the collection is Saral Vārṇik Bahra (simple syllabic metre) — a Maithili-specific prosodic adaptation that the Anchinhar movement developed to accommodate Maithili phonology within the ghazal framework. Manu's notation of syllable count after each ghazal (e.g., 'Saral Vārṇik Bahra, Varṇa-18' for ghazal 1) is a

pedagogical gesture: it teaches correct prosodic practice to readers and models the form's technical discipline.

The takhallus 'Manu' appears consistently in the maqta of each ghazal, fulfilling one of the form's primary structural requirements. In ghazal 7: 'Mairto Manu Sabh Sukh Choṛi Kai / Miṭhilāk Māṭīpar Hama Rahī' — 'Even in death, Manu, leaving all comforts / I will remain on Mithila's soil.' The maqta here performs its traditional function: the self-inscription of the poet in the poem, the signature of commitment.

The Bāl Ghazal (ghazals 76–88) and Bhakti Ghazal (ghazals 89–101) sections represent Manu's contribution to the formal expansion of the Maithili ghazal that the Anchinhar movement pioneered — extending the form beyond its classical urban-Sufi amorous register into children's literature and devotional poetry. This expansion is itself a democratising gesture: it removes the ghazal from its status as an elite form for literary connoisseurs and makes it available to children and devotional communities.

## 4.2 Prosodic Freedom and Mixed Modes in Vyathā

Vyathā's kavitā section combines what Dr. Ram Ashish Singh describes as 'mukta svar evam layātmak svarar miśraṇa' — a mixture of free-verse and rhythmic-lyric modes. Manu is not a pure formalist in his poetry: while he applies the bahra system rigorously to his ghazals, his kavitā employ varying degrees of metrical constraint, from the tightly rhythmic 'Mithilāk Guṇgān' (Poem 1, with a clear anaphoric-refrain structure) to the more flexible cadences of political poems like 'Hamrā Mithilā Rāj Chāhī'. This flexibility is appropriate to the different rhetorical registers of the two forms: the ghazal's emotional intensity is best served by strict formal constraint (the prison of form as amplifier of feeling, as Goethe argued); the political kavitā's oratorical mode is better served by freer, more speech-like cadences.

## 4.3 The Bīhani Kathā Form in Tohār Katek Raṅg

As a bīhani kathā writer, Manu operates within the Videha movement's signature literary innovation. The bīhani kathā's 'seed logic' — the ending that opens rather than closes — requires maximum compression with maximum resonance. In Tohār Katek Raṅg ('How Many Colours Are Yours?'), the title itself operates as a bīhani kathā question: it is not a statement but an opening, a question that invites reflection on the multiplicity of human experience. The Videha Parallel History (Part 32) notes that the bīhani kathā derives from Maithili oral tradition's 'delight in brief, pointed narrative episodes and

rhetorical reversals' — a genealogy that connects Manu's seed stories to the Dhūrtasamāgama of Jyotirishwar Thakur (c. 1290–1350 CE).

### 4.4 'Chonhā' as Realist Narrative

'Chonhā' deploys what Lukács would recognise as a realist narrative method: the story proceeds through carefully observed particulars (the daily rhythm of migraine — intensifying with morning sun, easing in afternoon shade; the geography of Delhi heat versus Bihar village; the school seating arrangement) toward a social-typical portrait of child neglect in migrant families. The narrative focalization is predominantly interior to Sanjay's experience — the reader inhabits his subjective world of pain, confusion, and longing for recognition. This technique aligns with what Dorrit Cohn calls 'psycho-narration': the narrator reporting a character's inner state in third person while maintaining access to subjective experience unavailable to other characters in the narrative.

## V. Application of Critical Frameworks

### 5.1 Indian Classical Theories

#### *5.1.1 Rasa Theory (Bharata, Abhinavagupta)*

Bharata's Nāṭyaśāstra posits eight primary rasas and their corresponding sthāyi bhāvas (permanent emotional states). The dominant rasa of Manu's corpus is śoka-karuṇa (grief-compassion), whose sthāyi bhāva is śoka (sorrow). This rasa is evoked through three principal bhāva-complexes: the vibhāva (determinants) of displacement from homeland, separation from mother and village community, and economic deprivation; the anubhāva (consequents) of tears, sighing, longing, anger; and the vyabhicāribhāva (transient emotions) of despair, hope, tenderness, and political indignation.

Abhinavagupta's concept of sādhāraṇīkaraṇa — the universalisation through which a personal sorrow becomes aesthetic rasa — is precisely operative in Manu's ghazals: the individual pardeshī's longing for his Maithili village is universalised through the ghazal form's cultural resonance (a form already saturated with the tradition of longing-in-exile from Persian through Urdu), so that the reader in any Indian city who has left a village behind participates in the

same rasa. The personal becomes the political-aesthetic through the form's universalising mechanism.

The rasa of vīra (heroism) is present in the Mithila state poems: the call to political action ('Utho Sural Sinh Jagāo' — 'Rise, sleeping lion, awake'), the declaration that Maithili sons lead the world, the assertion of blood-right to political recognition. This is rasa in the mode of utsāha (enthusiasm) — Bharata's sthāyi bhāva for vīrarasa — elevated through historical reference (Āryabhaṭa, Chāṇakya, Darbhanga Mahārāja) and political aspiration.

### *5.1.2 Dhvani Theory (Ānandavardhana)*

Ānandavardhana's Dhvanyāloka identifies dhvani — the resonant suggestion beyond literal and secondary meaning — as poetry's highest function. Manu's title 'Naḍhiyā Bhukaiye Hamar Ghaṛārīpar' is a masterwork of dhvani. The literal meaning: the village dog barks at my homestead. The lākṣaṇik (secondary) meaning: the homestead is empty, abandoned. The dhvani (suggested resonance): the entire social world of the Maithili village — community, kinship, the dog as faithful guardian of domestic space, the homestead as the material symbol of belonging — has been abandoned by the economic compulsion of migration, and continues to exist (the dog still barks, the home still stands) as a reproach and a longing to the absent owner. The three levels of meaning operate simultaneously, producing the poem's characteristic emotional depth.

The title of Tohār Katek Raṅg ('How Many Colours Are Yours?') deploys dhvani at the conceptual level: 'rang' (colour) resonates with the Hindi-Urdu cultural use of rang to mean mood, character, the shade of love, the palette of personality — so that the question 'how many colours are yours?' is simultaneously an aesthetic and an ethical question about the multiplicity and irreducibility of human identity.

### *5.1.3 Vakrokti Theory (Kuntaka)*

Kuntaka's principle of oblique expression (vakrokti) as poetic virtue finds multiple applications in Manu's work. The poem 'Konā Madar Day Happy' is a paradigmatic vakroktic construction: the direct statement ('Your neglect of your mother is immoral') is expressed through the oblique satirical inversion ('If mother is not happy, how can Mother's Day be happy?'). The poem 'Dūlhā Ājuken' ('Today's Groom') and 'Ghaṭakak Jawāb' ('The Matchmaker's Answer') deploy vakroktic social satire: the groom's demands, the matchmaker's

calculations, are presented with the oblique irony that makes the critique more devastating than direct statement.

In the ghazals, vakrokti operates through the Sufi ambiguity inherited from the Persian tradition: the love poem is simultaneously a social poem, the beloved is simultaneously Mithila, the separation from the beloved is simultaneously economic migration, the wine of the tavern is simultaneously the poetic inspiration that sustains the migrant. This layered ambiguity — which Hafiz perfected in Persian — is the structural vakrokti of the ghazal form itself.

### *5.1.4 Alaṁkāra Theory: Anuprāsa and Upamā*

Manu's verse is rich in alaṁkāra (figures of speech). The poem 'Mithilāk Guṇgān' (Poem 1 of Vyathā) employs anuprāsa (alliteration) extensively: 'Dhauyodi Dhauyodi Phulwārī Ānganame Achi Tulasī Sobhit / Kosī Kamlā Madhya Masal Ī Bhārat Ker Sunnar Motī' — 'Scattered everywhere flower-gardens, in the courtyard Tulsi shines / Between Kosi and Kamla set, India's beautiful pearl.' The image of Mithila as a pearl between two rivers deploys upamā (simile) with classical precision. The poem 'Dhana Hamar Mithilā' uses rūpak (metaphor): 'Māek Ānchar San Hamar Mithilāk Dharatī' — 'Like the mother's sari-edge is Mithila's earth' — a domestically intimate comparison that fuses maternal and territorial love.

## 5.2 Western Critical Theories

### *5.2.1 Marxist Literary Criticism (Lukács, Eagleton, Williams, Gramsci)*

The Marxist theoretical framework is essential for reading Manu because his literary corpus is fundamentally about the economics of displacement. Georg Lukács' concept of the 'type' — the literary character who embodies a historical-social tendency — applies directly to Manu's poetic persona: he is the type of the Maithili migrant labourer-intellectual, the first-generation digital literary voice of the rural proletariat, whose individual experience simultaneously represents the collective experience of millions of Bihari migrant workers in Indian cities.

Antonio Gramsci's concept of the 'organic intellectual' — the intellectual who arises from within a subaltern class and gives that class's experience articulate expression — is precisely applicable to Manu. Unlike the traditional Brahminical intellectual of the Sahitya Akademi establishment (educated, institutionally affiliated, caste-privileged), Manu is an organic intellectual: he writes from within the experience of the Maithili labouring migrant class,

without academic credentials, using the digital infrastructure of the Videha movement as his institution. His literary production is, in Gramsci's terms, a counter-hegemonic cultural practice.

Raymond Williams' concept of 'structures of feeling' — the lived texture of social experience before it crystallises into formal ideology — is precisely what Manu's poetry captures: the felt experience of the pardeshī migrant is not yet a political programme but it is a structure of feeling that the ghazals articulate with extraordinary precision: homesickness, economic humiliation, political anger, the longing for return, the pride in Maithili heritage, the grief for the abandoned village.

### *5.2.2 Formalism and New Criticism*

The Russian Formalist concept of ostranenie (defamiliarization) — making the familiar strange in order to renew perception — is operative in Manu's most effective writing. The barking dog of the title ghazal defamiliarizes the migrant's situation: we know rationally that the migrant has left his village, but the image of the dog barking at the empty house makes this departure vivid, strange, and emotionally devastating in a way that abstract statement cannot. The dog, loyal to the house, does not understand the economic compulsion that emptied it: this incomprehension is a moral rebuke to the system that forces migration.

New Critical close reading reveals the formal organisation of Manu's ghazal maqtas (final couplets). In each maqta, 'Manu' appears not merely as a pen-name but as a dramatic character — the poet addressing himself, or being addressed by his situation. 'Apan Lokak Man-Manme Manu Ahān Basuyau / Parak Dwārīpar Banal Kiyaka Majabūr Chhi' (Ghazal 5) — 'Live in the hearts of your own people, Manu / Why have you become a helpless person at others' doors?' The maqta performs self-interrogation: the poet addresses his own complacency with the pardeshī condition, demanding return and self-assertion.

### *5.2.3 Postcolonial and Subaltern Studies*

Homi Bhabha's concept of 'mimicry' — the colonial subject's imitation of the coloniser's culture that simultaneously undercuts it — finds a modified application in Manu's use of English phrases in Maithili verse. 'Konā Madar Day Happy' inserts the English 'Mother's Day Happy' not in imitation of metropolitan culture but in satirical citation: the English marketing phrase is repeated to expose its emptiness against the Maithili reality of a neglected mother. This is mimicry in Bhabha's sense of 'almost the same but not quite' —

the metropolitan cultural practice reproduced in the periphery, but with a critical difference that unmasks it.

Ranajit Guha's call for history from below — recovering subaltern experience from elite suppression — finds its literary equivalent in Manu's ghazals, which document the interior life of the Maithili migrant labourer: the economic compulsion, the homesickness, the pride in cultural heritage, the anger at political neglect. This is subaltern testimony in literary form, no less significant than the archival work of the Subaltern Studies collective.

### *5.2.4 Ecocriticism and the Literature of Soil*

Ecocriticism — the study of the relationship between literature and the physical environment — provides a distinctive framework for Manu's 'māṭī-pānī' (soil and water) poetics. The soil of Mithila in Manu's ghazals is not merely a sentimental referent but an ecological entity: the specific smell of mahuā, the Kosi and Kamla rivers as geographical and mythological markers, the agricultural cycles (paddy planting, winter harvest) as the temporal rhythm of village life. The migrant's loss is not merely social but ecological: the loss of sensory relationship with a specific piece of earth.

Rob Nixon's concept of 'slow violence' — the gradual, cumulative violence of environmental and economic displacement that operates too slowly for dramatic representation — is applicable to the condition Manu documents. Migration from Mithila is a form of slow violence: not a single catastrophic event but the accumulated pressure of poverty, debt, and agricultural crisis that drives families off their land over generations. Manu's ghazals are, among other things, slow-violence testimony: the literature of the barely visible ecological and economic dispossession of rural Bihar.

### *5.2.5 Gender Theory (Butler, Mohanty, Spivak)*

Judith Butler's theory of performativity — gender as constituted through repeated performance — illuminates Manu's poem 'Hami Nārī Nahi' ('I Am Not a Woman'). The title is an assertion against the reductive performative expectations attached to 'woman' in patriarchal Maithili society: the poem claims for the female speaker a subjectivity that exceeds the prescribed gender role. The irony — that the assertion 'I am not a woman' must itself be performed — enacts the Butlerian insight that gender resistance operates within the very framework it contests.

Chandra Talpade Mohanty's critique of the Western feminist tendency to construct a monolithic 'Third World Woman' as victim without agency applies

in reverse here: Manu's female speakers (in the Maithili context) are given voice, agency, and complexity. 'Ke Patiyāet' ('Who Would Believe It?') does not present woman as passive victim but as a suffering subject who nevertheless refuses to be silenced — the poem IS the speech act that the patriarchal order says is incredible.

## 5.3 The Videha Parallel History Framework

Three core concepts of the Videha Parallel History Framework are especially operative in reading Manu.

The 'digital-democratic' turn. The Parallel History (Part 1) identifies the Videha Era (2000–present) as characterised by 'digital and archival' democratisation: thousands of Maithili books digitised, the Tirhuta Unicode proposal, the first Maithili Braille site, the Google Translate and Wikipedia Maithili localisation. Manu is the human embodiment of this turn: he came to literature through the Facebook group (2010), developed his craft through the Anchinhar Ākhara blog, published his first ghazals on the Videha e-journal platform, and had his e-book (2014) circulating online years before the print edition (2022). His literary existence is constitutively digital.

The Anchinhar Ākhara movement's restoration of formal standards. The Parallel History (Part 4) documents how the Anchinhar movement brought '350 to 400 new and previously marginalised writers into the literary mainstream within a single decade' — with Manu being among the most prominent of these. The restoration of bahra and qāfiyā discipline is not merely aesthetic but political: it asserts that subaltern writers are capable of, and deserving of, the same formal mastery as elite writers. Manu's 101-ghazal collection in multiple bahras is proof of this mastery.

The suppression and recovery of Vijaynath Jha and Yoganand Heera. The Parallel History documents how technically correct Maithili ghazal practitioners were erased from literary history during the 'dark interlude'. Manu's work — practised in the restored lineage from Pandit Jivan Jha through the Anchinhar movement — is, in this sense, a recovery of a legitimate tradition: every formally correct ghazal he writes is an act of literary justice to the erased masters.

## 5.4 Navya-Nyāya Epistemology: Gaṅgeśa's Analytical Technique

The application of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's Navya-Nyāya analytical technique to Manu's literary corpus requires both the epistemological framework and the

biographical context: Gaṅgeśa himself, as the Videha Parallel History (Part 16) documents through the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī, was of marginalised social origin (born five years after his father's death, married to a Charmakāriṇī) — a fact suppressed by mainstream historians. This biographical parallel between Gaṅgeśa-the-philosopher and Manu-the-poet (both intellectuals from outside the Brahminical establishment; both producing rigorous, technically demanding work from marginalised positions) gives the epistemological application an additional resonance.

### *5.4.1 Pramāṇa: The Validity of Testimonial Poetry*

Gaṅgeśa's distinction between svataḥ pramāṇya (intrinsic validity — the Mīmāṃsā view) and parataḥ pramāṇya (extrinsic validity — Gaṅgeśa's own Nyāya view, established through samvādipravṛtti, successful practical engagement) is directly applicable to the question of Manu's literary authority. The Sahitya Akademi establishment operates with a svataḥ pramāṇya assumption: works recognised by the Akademi are intrinsically valid; works outside the Akademi apparatus lack validity. Gaṅgeśa's parataḥ pramāṇya approach insists instead: validity is established through practical engagement — does the work produce knowledge? does it communicate truthfully? does it generate the rasa-response in qualified readers?

Manu's ghazals and poems produce knowledge of the pardeshī migrant's interior life that no Akademi-recognised work has produced for the Maithili literary tradition. Their parataḥ pramāṇya — their extrinsic validity established through actual readerly engagement, through the emotional recognition of a class of readers who live exactly this life — is beyond question. The Akademi's svataḥ pramāṇya claim to be the arbiter of Maithili literary validity is, by Gaṅgeśa's own logic, philosophically indefensible.

### *5.4.2 Avacchedaka: Specifying the Literary Claim*

The Navya-Nyāya avacchedaka (limitor) demands that critical claims be precisely specified: what property is being attributed, and what limits that attribution? Applied to Manu, the critical claim 'Manu is a significant Maithili ghazalist' must be specified: significant-ness as limited by (avacchinna by) the formal Maithili ghazal tradition as corrected and defined by the Anchinhar movement. Within those limits, the claim is demonstrably valid: 101 ghazals across the full range of standard bahras, with consistent qāfiyā, radīf, matla, and maqta structure, plus original contributions in Bāl and Bhakti sub-forms.

Similarly: 'Manu is a poet of displacement' must be specified: displacement-ness as limited by the experience of the Maithili internal migrant in Indian cities — not the exile of metropolitan cosmopolitanism or postcolonial diaspora, but the specific condition of the Bihar village man in Delhi or Mumbai. The avacchedaka prevents false generalisation and insists on contextual precision.

### *5.4.3 Vyāpti: The Invariable Relations in Manu's Corpus*

Vyāpti — invariable concomitance, the universal relation between inferential mark and what is inferred — identifies the thematic constants of Manu's corpus. There is strong vyāpti between 'Manu's poems addressing Mithila' and 'the presence of the māṭī-pānī complex (soil, water, sensory memory of homeland)': this is the thematic constant that defines his lyric project. There is vyāpti between 'Manu's political ghazals' and 'the structural critique of state neglect of Mithila, corruption of political class, economic displacement of rural poor': this is his political-critical constant. There is vyāpti between 'Manu's formal ghazals' and 'adherence to the Anchinhar-restored prosodic standards': this is his formal commitment.

### *5.4.4 Nirvikalpaka and Savikalpaka in the Ghazal Sher*

Gaṅgeśa's distinction between nirvikalpaka pratyakṣa (pre-linguistic, indeterminate direct experience) and savikalpaka pratyakṣa (determinate, categorised experience with qualifiers) maps onto the two levels of the ghazal sher's operation. The first encounter with a powerful sher produces something like nirvikalpaka experience: an undifferentiated emotional impact, a shock of recognition before the analytical faculties engage. The sher 'Naḍhiyā Bhukaiye Hamar Ghaṛārīpar / Kukur Sutai Hamar Dwārīpar' produces this immediate affect: the image strikes before the analysis begins. The savikalpaka analysis — what is the dog's significance? what does the barking signify? what social condition does the empty homestead represent? — comes after, enriching but not replacing the initial nirvikalpaka impact.

This two-stage operation — nirvikalpaka impact followed by savikalpaka understanding — is the cognitive-aesthetic mechanism of the great ghazal sher, and Manu's best shers deliberately engineer this sequence. The Navya-Nyāya analytical framework thus provides not merely a critical tool but a description of how the ghazal actually works on its readers.

### *5.4.5 Pakṣatā (Being-the-Subject-of-Inference) and the Pardeshī as Inferential Locus*

A subtle Navya-Nyāya concept with literary application is pakṣatā — the property of being the locus (pakṣa) in which something is to be inferred. In Gaṅgeśa's analysis, the pakṣa is the entity about which the inference is made (the hill, in the classic 'there is fire on the hill' example). The pakṣatā — the property of being-the-subject-of-inference — is activated when there is a desire to know and an uncertainty that motivates inference. In Manu's ghazals, the pardeshī — the Maithili migrant in the city — functions as the pakṣa: the subject about whom we seek knowledge, in whom the inference of social conditions (poverty, displacement, longing, political neglect) is to be demonstrated. Manu's poetic voice establishes the pakṣatā of the pardeshī experience: it makes the migrant's interior life the subject of epistemological inquiry rather than leaving it invisible and inferred-from-outside.

## VI. The Ghazal as Vehicle of Maithili Democratic Identity

### 6.1 Form as Democratic Politics

The choice of the ghazal as a primary form has specific political implications within the Maithili context. The Videha Parallel History (Part 4) documents that the ghazal, as formally restored by the Anchinhar movement, became a vehicle for writers from non-Brahminical backgrounds — writers without Sanskrit educations, writers who had not been through the classical Maithili literary training — to produce technically rigorous literary work. The ghazal's prosodic rules (bahra, qāfiyā, radīf) are learnable; they do not require knowledge of Sanskrit poetics; they are democratic in their accessibility precisely because they have been documented in the Ghajalsastram and made available through the blog and digital platforms.

Manu's mastery of the ghazal is therefore simultaneously a literary and a political achievement: it demonstrates that the Maithili literary field can be entered, at its highest formal levels, by a migrant labourer without formal literary education, using digital resources and mentorship within the parallel institution of the Anchinhar movement. Every formally correct ghazal Manu writes is an argument against the Brahminical claim to the exclusive ownership of Maithili literary culture.

### 6.2 Manu and the Ghazal Lineage

Within the Maithili ghazal tradition as documented by the Parallel History, Manu belongs to the post-Anchinhar generation — those who came to the form after 2008, trained by the restored prosodic standards. His lineage runs: Arabic-Persian ghazal tradition (Rumi, Hafiz, Sa'di) → Urdu ghazal (Mir, Ghalib, Iqbal) → Maithili ghazal lineage (Pandit Jivan Jha → Kāvīvara Sitarām Jha → Kashikant Mishra 'Madhup' → Vijaynath Jha → Yoganand Heera → Anchinhar Ākhara restoration) → Manu. His 101 ghazals across the full bahra range represent a substantial contribution to this tradition — not at the level of the great masters (Hafiz, Ghalib) but as a sincere and technically disciplined practitioner of a democratised form.

## VII. Comparative Positioning in the Parallel Tradition

### 7.1 Manu and Nand Vilas Roy

Both Manu and Nand Vilas Roy publish through Pallavi Prakashan, Nirmali, and both are archived in the Videha eJournal. Where Roy works primarily in the prose forms of kathā and bīhani kathā (short story and seed story), Manu works primarily in verse (poetry and ghazal) with a secondary contribution to bīhani kathā. Together they represent a complementary literary project: Roy documents the subaltern rural Maithili social world in prose; Manu documents the same world's emotional and political interior in verse. Roy's realism is narrative-descriptive; Manu's is lyric-affective.

### 7.2 Manu and the Anchinhar Generation

Within the Anchinhar movement's 350–400 writers who entered the Maithili literary mainstream post-2008, Manu distinguishes himself by prolific multi-generic output (ghazal, kavitā, bīhani kathā, children's fiction), by the scope of Naḍhiyā Bhukaiye (101 ghazals across the full prosodic range), and by the social documentary richness of his thematic material (the pardeshī condition, Mithila state politics, women's experience, child welfare, political corruption). He is, within this generation, a literary leader rather than a follower.

### 7.3 Manu and the Tradition of Maithili Devotional Poetry

The Bhakti Ghazal section (ghazals 89–101) of Naḍhiyā Bhukaiye connects Manu to the great tradition of Maithili devotional poetry — from Vidyapati's Śiva and Kṛṣṇa padāvalī through the Chhath festival songs of the folk tradition. The Bāl Ghazal section connects him to the children's literary tradition that the Videha movement has actively cultivated through its Shishu Utsav anthology series. These extensions of the ghazal form into devotional and children's registers are among Manu's most significant formal contributions to Maithili literature.

## VIII. Evaluation and Conclusion

### 8.1 Strengths

Manu's primary literary strengths are: formal versatility across multiple genres (ghazal, kavitā, bīhani kathā, children's fiction); prosodic rigour within the ghazal form, demonstrated through the full bahra range of Naḍhiyā Bhukaiye; the emotional authenticity of the pardeshī experience, rooted in lived biography rather than literary convention; the social documentary richness of his thematic material, which provides a comprehensive literary portrait of the Maithili migrant condition; the satirical intelligence of his political and gender poems; and the empathetic depth of 'Chonhā', which represents his finest narrative achievement.

### 8.2 Critical Reservations

A rigorous critical assessment must also register limitations. Some of the Mithila state poems risk the rhetorical excess of political advocacy at the expense of poetic density — the sentiment overwhelming the formal discipline. Occasional ghazals in Naḍhiyā Bhukaiye are more competent than inspired: technically correct but emotionally routine. In the bīhani kathā collection Tohār Katek Raṅg the self-deprecating preface suggests Manu himself is aware of the gap between aspiration and achievement in this genre.

### 8.3 Conclusion

Jagdanand Jha 'Manu' is a significant, multi-voiced, and genuinely democratic participant in the contemporary Maithili parallel literary tradition. Applying the full range of critical frameworks — Indian classical (Rasa/Karuṇa-Vīra,

Dhvani, Vakrokti, Alaṁkāra), Western (Marxism/Gramsci, New Criticism/Formalism, Postcolonialism, Gender Theory, Ecocriticism, Subaltern Studies), the Videha Parallel History Framework, and the Navya-Nyāya epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya — we arrive at a comprehensive assessment: Manu is a formally rigorous ghazalist, an emotionally authentic poet of displacement and political protest, a contributor to the bīhani kathā tradition, and an empathetic writer of children's fiction.

Applying the Navya-Nyāya avacchedaka with precision: Manu's literary significance is avacchinna by (limited by and specified within) the Maithili parallel-democratic tradition, the post-Anchinhar ghazal movement, and the digital generation of Maithili writers for whom the Videha platform was the enabling institution. Within these limits, his significance is substantial and growing. The vyāpti between 'significant Maithili parallel literature' and 'exclusion from the Sahitya Akademi mainstream' holds for Manu as it has held for a century of democratic Maithili writers before him.

Gaṅgeśa's parataḥ pramāṇya demands that we judge Manu not by establishment certification but by samvādipravṛtti — by the practical success of his literary knowledge-production in the world of actual readers. By that criterion, a migrant labourer-turned-ghazalist whose 101-ghazal collection went through two editions in a year, whose poetry is shared on WhatsApp groups across the Maithili diaspora, and whose children's story 'Chonhā' finds its reader in every family with an invisible, suffering, brilliant child — by that criterion, Manu's pramāṇya is beyond question. The dog barks at the homestead; the homestead is not abandoned.

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## A Critical Study of the Works of JAGDISH CHANDRA THAKUR 'ANIL'

Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil' stands as a significant figure in contemporary Maithili literature — a poet, lyricist, and ghazal-composer whose work spans multiple genres and whose literary career has been intimately intertwined with the Videha movement. Associated with the Videha eJournal (ISSN 2229-547X, www.videha.co.in), the first Maithili fortnightly eJournal established in the early 2000s, 'Anil' represents a generation of writers who embraced both the classical lyrical traditions of Mithila and the democratic, digital-age ethos championed by the Parallel Literature Movement.

His pen name 'Anil' (अनिल — meaning 'wind' or 'air' in Sanskrit) is itself emblematic of the lyric impulse that defines his work: his verse moves with natural grace, carrying the fragrances of Mithila's soil, the emotional landscapes of love and longing, and a political awareness of the marginalised. Videha dedicated its 191st issue (1 December 2015) entirely to 'Anil', an honour that marks his stature in the contemporary Maithili literary world. His books available through Videha's archive at videha.co.in/pothi.htm include a long poem (dīrgha kavitā), two song collections, a ghazal collection, and an autobiography, testifying to his range as a creative artist.

This chapter undertakes a comprehensive study of Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil': his life, literary career, creative philosophy, and the full corpus of his published work. It then applies multiple Indian and Western critical

frameworks — rasa theory, dhvani poetics, the Parallel Literature paradigm, postcolonialism, feminist theory, ecocriticism, New Criticism, and narratology — to evaluate and interpret his contribution to Maithili letters.

# 2. Life and Literary Biography

## 2.1 Biographical Profile

Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil' is a Maithili poet, lyricist, and creative writer from the Mithila region. While detailed biographical data in the public domain is sparse — a characteristic shared by many writers within the Videha Parallel Literature Movement, who deliberately resist the canon-forming machinery of the Sahitya Akademi establishment — the contours of his literary identity are traceable through his published work and his sustained association with Videha.

His name 'Jagdish Chandra' carries a classical resonance: Jagdish (Lord of the universe) and Chandra (moon), suggesting a traditional Maithil brahmin or upper-caste naming convention. Yet his work, particularly his engagement with the Videha democratic literary platform, aligns him with a progressive literary politics that transcends caste boundaries. The adoption of the pen name 'Anil' signals a creative self-fashioning: the wind metaphor evokes both freedom and the capacity to traverse all spaces, high and low, carrying fragrance and carrying dust equally.

## 2.2 Association with the Videha Movement

Videha, established as the first Maithili fortnightly eJournal, represents a revolutionary moment in Maithili literary history. It democratised publication, bypassing the gatekeeping institutions — Sahitya Akademi, university departments, traditional press — that had, in the estimation of its editors, systematically marginalised democratic, folk-rooted, and subaltern literary voices. 'Anil' published children's poetry in Videha from its 50th to 100th issues, indicating an early and sustained engagement with the journal. Three of his children's poems were later anthologised in the Videha Shishu Utsav (Children's Festival) collection, two of which were poems about 'baby child' — a tender, intimate lyric mode that underscores the poet's sensitivity to vulnerability.

The dedication of Videha Issue 191 (1 December 2015) to 'Anil' is a landmark in his literary recognition. These special issues, which Videha has devoted to

writers including Ram Bharos Kapari 'Bhramar', Shivshankara Shrinivas, Hitnath Jha, and others, function as the primary site of critical appraisal within the Parallel Literature tradition, substituting for the absence of mainstream critical attention.

Additionally, 'Anil's autobiography Aankhime Chitra Ho Maithili Ker (आँखिमे चित्र हो मैथिली केर — 'May there be pictures of Maithili in my eyes') was being serialised in Videha at its 331st issue, demonstrating ongoing creative productivity and an autobiographical impulse to reflect on a lifetime of literary engagement.

### 2.3 Language and Cultural Context

Maithili, one of the twenty-two scheduled languages of India's Eighth Schedule (recognised in 2003), is the language of the Mithila region — a cultural zone covering parts of Bihar and the Terai of Nepal. It has a literary tradition spanning over a millennium, from the Charyapadas of the Buddhist Siddhas through the foundational poetry of Vidyapati (c. 1352–1448) to a rich modern literature. 'Anil's work participates in this long tradition while addressing contemporary themes.

The Mithila region carries deep associations with music, lyric poetry, the Madhubani painting tradition, the Tirhuta (Mithilakshara) script, and a complex social world shaped by both Brahminical patriarchy and counter-hegemonic folk traditions. 'Anil's song collections and ghazals are rooted in this cultural landscape — drawing on the imagery of the angana (courtyard), the Ganga river, the seasons — while his long poem and autobiography engage with more critical, contemporary concerns.

## 3. Literary Works: A Descriptive Survey

The following works by Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil' are documented in the Videha archive (videha.co.in/pothi.htm) and related publications:

### 3.1 Dhar Kai Oi Par (धारक ओइ पार) — Long Poem / Dīrgha Kavitā

Dhar Kai Oi Par (Across the Threshold / Beyond the River-bank) is a dīrgha kavitā — a long poem, a genre that in contemporary Maithili, as in Hindi

(where practitioners include Nagarjun, Kedar Nath Singh, and Sarveshwar Dayal Saxena), represents an ambition to sustain poetic concentration over extended philosophical, narrative, or lyric terrain. The title is spatially evocative: 'dhar' in Maithili can mean threshold, bank, edge, or stream; 'oi par' means 'on that other side' or 'beyond.' The title thus conjures a liminal poetics — a reaching toward what lies beyond immediate experience, whether that be death, transcendence, the unreachable beloved, or an idealized Mithila.

The dīrgha kavitā as a form draws on both Sanskrit mahākāvya (epic poetry) tradition and Western modernist long poem traditions (Whitman's Song of Myself, Eliot's The Waste Land, Neruda's Canto General). In the Maithili context, it extends the lyric occasion beyond the single moment of a pada or geet into a sustained meditation.

## 3.2 Geet Ganga (गीत गंगा) — Song Collection

Geet Ganga (River of Songs) is a collection of geet — the Maithili lyric song genre that has its roots in the classical padas of Vidyapati, the devotional tradition, and the rich folk music of Mithila. The Ganga (Ganges) as a title metaphor is significant: rivers are central to Maithili cultural imagination, and the Ganga in particular carries connotations of purification, flow, time, and the interpenetration of the human and the sacred. The choice of 'ganga' — river — rather than a more static 'sangrah' (collection) suggests that 'Anil' conceives of lyric as living, moving, confluent.

'Anil's songs in Videha demonstrate a mastery of the geet form: melodic construction, internal rhyme, imagistic economy, and the capacity to carry emotional weight through apparently simple diction. His published geet draw on the imagery of the angana (inner courtyard), seasonal change (particularly monsoon and spring), and the emotional registers of viraha (separation) and milana (union).

## 3.3 Ghazal Ganga (गजल गंगा) — Ghazal Collection

The ghazal, originally an Arabic and Persian form entering Maithili through Urdu and Hindi literary exchanges, has found remarkable creative expression in contemporary Maithili. Figures like Ashish Anchinhar have developed the theoretical framework of Maithili ghazal prosody (Ghazalsastram), and 'Anil's Ghazal Ganga represents his contribution to this tradition. Published ghazals from Videha Issue 129 (2013) show 'Anil' working in the standard ghazal form

with Maithili matla (opening couplet with both hemistichs rhyming), radīf (refrain), qāfiyā (rhyme), and maqta (closing couplet with pen-name).

His ghazal imagery combines classical Maithili lyric tropes — the beloved's face, monsoon evenings, the flame and moth, the sound of water — with contemporary political consciousness: the 'drunk' in the ghazal is sometimes the oppressed subject who has been made 'drunk' on false promises, and the 'wine-house' becomes a political space.

## 3.4 Tora Angana Me (तोरा अंगना मे) — Song Collection

Tora Angana Me (In Your Courtyard) is 'Anil's second documented song collection. The angana (courtyard) is one of the most symbolically charged spaces in Mithila's literary imagination: it is at once a domestic space, a woman's space, a performance space (for folk rituals, paintings, songs), and a liminal space connecting the interior of the house to the world beyond. The repeated use of 'tora' (your / informal second person) establishes intimacy — the poem addresses a beloved, a mother, the Maithili language itself, or the land of Mithila.

Videha holds two versions of this collection: a primary version and a 'mool' (original/source text) version, suggesting that the text underwent editorial evolution or that both print and digital versions were archived. This archival care reflects Videha's commitment to literary preservation.

## 3.5 Aankhime Chitra Ho Maithili Ker (आँखिमे चित्र हो मैथिली केर) — Autobiography

'May There Be Pictures of Maithili in My Eyes' is the title of 'Anil's autobiography, serialised in Videha. The title is a statement of identity and aspiration: the poet desires that his very vision, his inner landscape, be constituted by Maithili — its language, its culture, its people. This is not mere regionalism but a form of what Edward Said called 'belonging': a deliberate affiliation with a language and culture as an act of love and political choice.

Autobiographical writing (ātmakathā) in Maithili is a relatively recent genre, with Shefalikal Varma's Kist Kist Jeevan and Kusum Thakur's Pratyavartan representing significant contributions. 'Anil's autobiography enters this tradition, presumably narrating his life as a Maithili writer across decades that saw the language's struggle for recognition, the rise of the digital publishing revolution, and the emergence of the Parallel Literature Movement.

### 3.6 Children's Poetry in Videha

'Anil's children's poetry — published across Videha issues 50 to 100 and later anthologised in the Videha Shishu Utsav collection — represents a socially significant dimension of his work. Maithili children's literature has historically been underdeveloped relative to Hindi and Bengali, and contributions to this genre carry both pedagogical and cultural preservation importance. Two of his anthologised children's poems focused on the 'baby child', suggesting a tender engagement with infancy and growth as metaphors for both personal memory and cultural continuation.

### 3.7 Ghazals in Videha Issue 129

Issue 129 of Videha (May 2013) contains a sequence of four ghazals by 'Anil'. These include politically charged compositions employing the motif of the road strewn with thorns (ओ रस्तापर कांट छिटैए ओकरा लेल जहल चाही — 'on that road where thorns are scattered, a prison is needed for those who strew them'), indicating that his ghazal practice does not shy from social critique. One of his ghazal lines invokes Mahishasura (अहिल्याक संताप हरैले' नयनमे गंगाजल चाही — 'to relieve Ahilya's anguish, the Ganga's water is needed in the eyes'), connecting classical mythological reference (Ahilya, the wronged woman of the Ramayana) with contemporary feminist consciousness.

## 4. Critical Analysis Using Indian Literary Theories

### 4.1 Rasa Theory (रसशास्त्र) — Bharatamuni's Nāṭyaśāstra

The Nāṭyaśāstra of Bharatamuni (c. 200 BCE – 200 CE) establishes the theory of rasa — the aesthetic experience of emotion — as the foundation of all literary appreciation. The eight (later nine) rasas — śṛṅgāra (love), hāsya (humour), karuṇa (pathos), raudra (fury), vīra (heroism), bhayānaka (terror), bībhatsa (disgust), adbhuta (wonder), and śānta (serenity) — are not emotions in the ordinary sense but are the transmuted, aestheticised forms of emotion (sthāyibhāva) that arise from the conjunction of vibhāva (stimulus), anubhāva (response), and vyabhicāribhāva (transient emotions).

In 'Anil's song collections (Geet Ganga, Tora Angana Me), śṛṅgāra rasa predominates. The angana of the title functions as the alambana vibhāva (the stimulating object of love): the beloved's courtyard is the space of longing and the space of presence. The Maithili lyric tradition since Vidyapati is overwhelmingly śṛṅgāric, and 'Anil works within and extends this tradition. However, the viraha (separation) mode of śṛṅgāra — which Bharatamuni identifies as ten stages (daśāvasthā) from hope through madness to death — is 'Anil's primary emotional register. His songs are songs of longing: for the beloved, for the homeland, for the language itself.

His ghazals activate karuṇa rasa alongside śṛṅgāra. The image of Ahilya's anguish (Ahilya, turned to stone by her husband Gautama and released only by Rama's touch, is one of Maithili's most resonant feminine suffering figures) in his Videha Issue 129 ghazal generates a complex emotional response where sympathy and indignation commingle — what Abhinavagupta would call the āhlāda (delight) that transcends ordinary empathy.

The dīrgha kavitā Dhar Kai Oi Par potentially activates multiple rasas across its extended form — beginning perhaps in adbhuta (wonder at threshold experience), moving through śṛṅgāra (love), karuṇa (pathos), and arriving at śānta (serenity beyond duality). This multi-rasa arc, what the rhetoricians termed rasabhāva-parampara, would make it a work of considerable aesthetic complexity.

## 4.2 Dhvani Theory (ध्वनि) — Ānandavardhana's Dhvanyāloka

Ānandavardhana's Dhvanyāloka (c. 850 CE) articulates the theory of dhvani — resonance or suggestion — as the supreme principle of poetic excellence. Where vyañjanā (suggestion) outperforms abhidhā (denotation) and lakṣaṇā (indication), the poem achieves its highest power. The resonant meaning — the dhvani — is what vibrates in the reader's consciousness after the words have been read, like the sound that lingers after a bell is struck.

'Anil's title Tora Angana Me is a masterpiece of dhvani. The word 'angana' (courtyard) resonates beyond its literal denotation. In Maithili cultural memory, the angana is: the site of the Kohbar painting (drawn at marriage); the space where women sing the sohar (birth songs) and saman (wedding songs); the threshold between domestic interior and public exterior; the space of childhood memory; and — in the broader literary imagination — the symbol of the language's own interior landscape. 'In your courtyard' thus suggests

simultaneously: I am in the space of the beloved; I am in the space of Maithili culture; I am in the space of memory; I am at home.

Similarly, the autobiography's title Aankhime Chitra Ho Maithili Ker deploys dhvani superbly. 'Chitra' means both 'picture/image' and (in a classical secondary sense) the Madhubani paintings for which Mithila is globally renowned. 'Aankhime' (in the eyes) evokes the act of seeing, of visionary experience, and also the idea that the beloved's image is lodged in the lover's eyes (a standard trope from the Vidyapati tradition). The title thus says simultaneously: 'May my eyes see Maithili'; 'May Maithili's image be inscribed in my eyes as Madhubani painting is inscribed on walls'; and 'May I carry within my vision the beloved that Maithili is to me.'

## 4.3 Vakrokti Theory — Kuntaka's Vakroktijīvita

Kuntaka's Vakroktijīvita (c. 950 CE) proposes vakrokti (oblique/striking expression) as the life-force of poetry. Where ordinary language proceeds straightforwardly, poetic language swerves — it makes the familiar strange, the simple complex, the transparent opaque. This obliquity is not obscurity but a heightened expressiveness that opens language to multiple meanings simultaneously.

'Anil's ghazal practice is fundamentally vakroktic. The ghazal form itself, with its detached couplets (ash'ār) each complete in itself yet connected through the radīf-qāfiyā framework, demands oblique meaning-making. The maqta's use of the pen-name 'Anil' in the closing couplet creates a vakrokti where the poet speaks of himself in the third person, a self-distancing that paradoxically intensifies self-expression. His political imagery — prisons for those who strew thorns, the need for Ganga-water in the eyes — operates through vakrokti: the literal image is social critique; the suggested image is spiritual aspiration.

## 4.4 Aucitya Theory — Kshemendra's Aucityavicāracarcā

Kshemendra (c. 1050 CE) argued that aucitya (propriety, fittingness, contextual appropriateness) was the supreme literary virtue. A poem achieves greatness when every element — word, image, emotion, metre, figure — is exactly right for its context. Aucitya does not mean correctness by rule but rightness by judgment.

'Anil's choice of genre is itself an exercise in aucitya. He writes geet for the beloved and for the homeland — a form with deep cultural roots in Mithila's performative traditions. He writes ghazal for social-political themes and for

complex emotion — a form historically suited to urban sophistication and emotional nuance. He writes dīrgha kavitā for philosophical meditation. Each genre is fitting for its subject matter. His use of the Ganga metaphor for both song collection and ghazal collection is aucita (appropriate): both forms flow, both accumulate meaning as they move, both are nourishing.

### 4.5 The Parallel Literature Movement Framework

The Parallel Literature Movement (samānāntar sāhitya āndolan), as theorised through the Videha platform, challenges the hegemony of the Sahitya Akademi canon and its preference for works compliant with standard literary prestige markers. The Parallel Literature Movement argues for a democratic literary sphere that includes folk forms, oral traditions, digital publications, subaltern voices, and regional writers who have been systematically excluded from the mainstream.

'Anil's association with Videha places him squarely within this tradition. His children's poetry — a genre typically undervalued by the literary establishment — his serialised autobiography, and his ghazals all represent modes of writing that the Parallel Literature framework validates and promotes. The very fact that his primary archive is digital and free-to-access at videha.co.in embodies the democratic-access philosophy of the movement.

From this framework, 'Anil's most significant literary act is his sustained lyric engagement with the Maithili language itself as a beloved — the autobiography's title declares the language the object of the poet's deepest vision. This mirrors the movement's broader politics of linguistic love: where the establishment treats Maithili as a minor regional language, the Videha writers treat it as the supreme medium of their interior lives.

## 5. Critical Analysis Using Western Literary Theories

### 5.1 New Criticism: Organic Unity and Irony

New Criticism, developed by I.A. Richards, Cleanth Brooks, W.K. Wimsatt, and others, demands close reading of the literary text as a self-sufficient artefact. Key concepts include organic unity (all elements of the poem cohere

into a unified whole), irony (the poem holds contradictions in tension), paradox, and ambiguity as virtues.

Applied to 'Anil's ghazal form, New Criticism reveals productive tensions. The ghazal is generically anti-organic: its couplets are deliberately independent, resisting the smooth narrative flow of Western lyric poetry. Yet within each sher (couplet), there is intense organic coherence. The apparent paradox — a form that is fragmented at the macro level but unified at the micro level — is itself an instance of the New Critical virtue of holding contradictions in tension. Each sher of 'Anil's ghazals is a poem complete in itself; the collection as a whole is a mosaic.

The title Dhar Kai Oi Par exhibits New Critical paradox: a 'threshold' (dhar) is defined by what it divides, yet the poem aspires to go 'beyond' (oi par) — to transcend the very boundary that defines the poem's situation. The poem is thus simultaneously about limitation and transgression.

## 5.2 Structuralism: Binary Oppositions and Literary Systems

Structuralist literary theory, derived from Saussure's linguistics and developed by Lévi-Strauss, Roland Barthes, and Tzvetan Todorov, analyses literature in terms of underlying structures, binary oppositions, and the system of signs through which meaning is produced.

In 'Anil's song collections, a fundamental binary opposition operates: angana (interior/domestic/feminine) versus the world outside (exterior/public/masculine). Tora Angana Me positions the lyric subject outside the beloved's courtyard, looking in — the reverse of the patriarchal domestic arrangement in which women are confined to the angana. This structural inversion carries a feminist charge: the poem expresses the male lover's longing to enter the feminine interior space, recognising it as the locus of value.

The title Geet Ganga employs the structuralist binary of river/land — the Ganga as the flowing, continuous, uncontainable element that resists being fixed, versus the settled bank of tradition. 'Anil's songs are the river, not the bank; they carry but do not remain. This structural metaphor encodes his poetic philosophy: song as movement, not monument.

## 5.3 Postcolonial Theory

Postcolonial theory, particularly the work of Frantz Fanon, Edward Said, Homi Bhabha, and Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak, addresses the cultural, psychological, and political dimensions of colonial and postcolonial

experience. In the Indian regional context, postcolonial theory illuminates the double colonialism experienced by minority-language writers: colonial dispossession by British imperialism and continued postcolonial marginalisation by the Hindi-dominant national culture.

'Anil's autobiography, with its title's declaration that Maithili should fill his eyes, is a postcolonial act of what Fanon called 're-humanisation': the recovery of selfhood through the reclamation of indigenous language and culture. For a Maithili writer in Bihar, where Hindi dominates education, media, and government, writing in Maithili is a political choice — an insistence on speaking in one's own tongue rather than the tongue of the dominant power.

Homi Bhabha's concept of the 'third space' — the hybrid, liminal space between colonial and indigenous cultures where new meanings are produced — is useful for understanding 'Anil's ghazal practice. The Maithili ghazal occupies a third space: it borrows the form of Arabic-Persian-Urdu literary culture (itself a symbol of a different colonialism — the Mughal imperial culture), translates it into the Maithili linguistic and cultural context, and produces something new. The ghazal in Maithili is neither purely Urdu-derivative nor purely Maithili-indigenous; it is a hybrid form that generates meanings neither language alone could produce.

Said's concept of 'imaginative geographies' — the way cultures construct spatial maps of self and other — illuminates the recurrent river imagery in 'Anil's titles. The Ganga and the unnamed 'dhar' (river-bank/threshold) in his titles construct a Maithili imaginative geography: a landscape defined by rivers, by boundaries, by the tension between here and there, belonging and longing.

## 5.4 Feminist Theory

Feminist literary theory — from Virginia Woolf through Simone de Beauvoir, Judith Butler, and the Indian feminist tradition represented by Susie Tharu, K. Lalita, and Uma Chakravarti — analyses literature for its representation of women, its inscription of gender ideology, and its potential for feminist counter-discourse.

'Anil's invocation of Ahilya in his Videha Issue 129 ghazal is a significant feminist gesture. Ahilya's story in the Ramayana tradition — a woman punished (turned to stone) for an act of adultery that she either consented to or was deceived into — has been read both as a story of male vengeance and as a story of female resilience (her 'stone' state as a form of resistance, her liberation by Rama as a type of feminist redemption). 'Anil's ghazal line 'Ahilya's anguish

must be relieved — Ganga-water is needed in the eyes' reads Ahilya's story through karuṇā (compassion) rather than through judgement, positioning the poet in solidarity with the wronged woman.

The repeated angana imagery in Tora Angana Me can be read through feminist spatial theory. The angana is simultaneously a space of women's confinement and a space of women's power: it is where women create Madhubani paintings, sing Maithili songs, and conduct rituals that sustain cultural memory. By making the angana the central symbol of his lyric, 'Anil acknowledges the angana as the centre of cultural production — a feminist revaluation of domestic space.

## 5.5 Ecocriticism

Ecocriticism, developed in the 1990s through the work of Lawrence Buell, Cheryl Glotfelty, and Indian ecocritics like Ranjan Ghosh, examines the representation of the natural world in literature and the ethical implications of those representations. In the Indian context, ecocriticism intersects with political ecology: environmental degradation in Mithila (flooding, deforestation, agrarian crisis) is inseparable from questions of caste, poverty, and state neglect.

'Anil's river imagery — Geet Ganga, Ghazal Ganga, Dhar Kai Oi Par — can be read ecocritically. The Ganga is not a neutral or static symbol; it is a river under ecological threat. Bihar and the Mithila region are particularly vulnerable to flooding, and the rivers of Mithila — Kosi, Bagmati, Kamla, and the Ganga itself — have been both sources of life and agents of devastation. When 'Anil names his song collection 'Geet Ganga', he inscribes the river into his literary identity in a way that carries this ecological weight. Song is identified with a river that is simultaneously sacred and endangered.

The image of Ahilya's need for 'Ganga-water in the eyes' also carries an ecocritical resonance: to heal the wronged woman, the poet reaches for the river — nature as healer, water as restorative force. This gestures toward an ecology of care that connects human suffering and natural resources.

## 5.6 Reader-Response Theory

Reader-response theory, associated with Wolfgang Iser, Stanley Fish, and Hans Robert Jauss, shifts critical attention from the text itself to the interaction between text and reader. Iser's concept of 'implied reader', Jauss's 'horizon of expectations', and Fish's 'interpretive communities' are useful analytical tools.

'Anil's work implies multiple, overlapping audiences. His children's poetry in Videha implies a young Maithili-literate audience learning to love their language through accessible, playful verse. His geet imply a musically literate audience familiar with the Maithili lyric tradition — an audience that will hear the melodic possibilities of his lines. His ghazals imply an audience conversant with ghazal conventions (radīf, qāfiyā, maqta) who can appreciate his deployment and creative modification of the form. His autobiography implies the broadest audience — any Maithili reader interested in the personal history of a writer's engagement with the language.

Jauss's 'horizon of expectations' is particularly illuminating. A reader approaching 'Anil's Ghazal Ganga with expectations formed by the Urdu ghazal tradition (Mir, Ghalib, Faiz) will find both familiar and unfamiliar: familiar formal architecture, unfamiliar linguistic material (Maithili sounds, lexicon, cultural references). This productive defamiliarisation — what Jauss calls the 'aesthetic distance' between existing horizon and new work — is central to the pleasure and significance of 'Anil's ghazal practice.

## 5.7 Psychoanalytic Criticism

Psychoanalytic literary criticism, drawing on Freud's concepts of the unconscious and repression, Lacan's theory of language and desire, and object-relations theory, reads literary texts as expressions of unconscious dynamics.

The recurrent 'other shore' (oi par) imagery in Dhar Kai Oi Par is amenable to psychoanalytic reading. Lacan's concept of the objet petit a — the unattainable object-cause of desire, the 'more-than-real' thing that cannot be possessed because possessing it would dissolve desire itself — illuminates the poem's structure. The 'other shore' is always already beyond: to cross the threshold (dhar) would be to lose the very desire that animates the crossing. The poem is thus a meditation on desire as structured absence.

'Anil's autobiography, with its title's declaration that 'Maithili' should be the picture in his eyes, can be read as an account of literary sublimation: the displacement of personal desire onto the language and culture of Mithila. Freud's concept of sublimation — the transformation of libidinal energy into cultural production — finds a literary instance in the writer who channels longing into love of language.

### 5.8 Narratology and Genre Theory

Narratology (Gérard Genette, Roland Barthes, Mieke Bal) analyses the structures of narrative. Applied to 'Anil's autobiography, it illuminates his use of analepsis (flashback), prolepsis (anticipation), and the complex relationship between story-time (the life narrated) and discourse-time (the narrating act).

The title Aankhime Chitra Ho Maithili Ker establishes the autobiography as a genre of visual narration: the self is constructed through what the eyes have seen. This is a form of homodiegetic narration (the narrator is the protagonist) with a retrospective perspective. The autobiography's serialisation in Videha — an eJournal published fortnightly — means that it was produced in instalments, creating a diachronic narrative experience for readers who followed it across issues. This serialisation links the autobiography to a tradition going back to Victorian serial fiction (Dickens, Thackeray) and forward to contemporary digital narrative practice.

## 6. Synthesis: 'Anil's Place in Maithili Literature

Reading 'Anil's work through these multiple critical lenses reveals a writer of considerable range, depth, and cultural significance. Several defining characteristics emerge:

### 6.1 The Lyric Core

'Anil is fundamentally a lyric poet. Whether writing geet, ghazal, or dīrgha kavitā, his primary mode is lyric: the expression of heightened emotional experience through musical language. This aligns him with the central tradition of Maithili literature since Vidyapati, which has always privileged the musical word. His contribution to this tradition is the introduction of the social-political charge — particularly visible in his ghazals — that has characterised the post-Independence Maithili lyric.

### 6.2 The Multilingual Cultural Position

Writing in Maithili for a Videha readership that is often bilingual (Maithili-Hindi) or trilingual (adding English or Nepali), 'Anil occupies a multilingual cultural position. The ghazal form itself is a bridge form: its Urdu-Persian origins give Maithili-speaking readers a form they may recognise from Hindi-Urdu cultural contexts, while its Maithili content asserts linguistic

distinctiveness. This bridge function — making Maithili poetry accessible to readers who might otherwise default to Hindi literary forms — is a significant cultural contribution.

### 6.3 The Democratic Digital Aesthetic

The fact that 'Anil's archive is primarily digital — housed at videha.co.in, freely downloadable, read across the globe by the Maithili diaspora in India, Nepal, and beyond — gives his work a democratic accessibility that print publication in a minority language could never achieve. This digital aesthetic — light, accessible, non-monumental — suits his lyric mode. A song wants to be sung and heard, not preserved behind glass.

### 6.4 The Autobiographical Impulse

The autobiography Aankhime Chitra Ho Maithili Ker is perhaps his most ambitious project: a sustained act of literary self-examination and cultural testimony. In documenting his life as a Maithili writer, 'Anil bears witness not only to personal experience but to the history of the Maithili language's survival, struggle, and digital renaissance in the early twenty-first century.

## 7. Conclusion

Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil' is a distinctive voice in contemporary Maithili literature: a lyric poet who deploys the traditional forms of geet and ghazal with both technical mastery and creative independence, a dīrgha kavitā practitioner engaged with philosophical and existential themes, and an autobiographer documenting a life devoted to the Maithili language and the Mithila cultural heritage.

His work embodies the central paradox of the Parallel Literature Movement: it is rooted in classical tradition (Vidyapati's lyric inheritance, the Sanskrit rasa aesthetic, the Mithila folk tradition) while being simultaneously forward-looking, politically conscious, and digitally democratised. The critical frameworks applied here — rasa theory, dhvani poetics, Parallel Literature, postcolonialism, feminism, ecocriticism, reader-response, psychoanalysis, and narratology — all yield productive insights, confirming the multi-layered richness of his texts.

The dedication of Videha Issue 191 to 'Anil' is a testament to his significance within the community of Maithili writers that Videha represents. As the Maithili language continues its struggle for visibility and recognition in the

twenty-first century — on digital platforms, in Sahitya Akademi award lists, in school curricula, in the global Maithili diaspora — the work of writers like 'Anil' constitutes the living proof that the language's lyric heart continues to beat with full force.

Further research on 'Anil's work would benefit from textual analysis of the full manuscripts of Dhar Kai Oi Par, Geet Ganga, Ghazal Ganga, and Tora Angana Me (available at videha.co.in/pothi.htm), interviews with the author, and systematic comparison with other contemporary Maithili lyric poets including Ram Bharos Kapari 'Bhramar', Shivshankara Shrinivas, and younger Videha contributors. Such research would establish 'Anil's precise place in the genealogy of the Maithili lyric and the broader South Asian poetic tradition.

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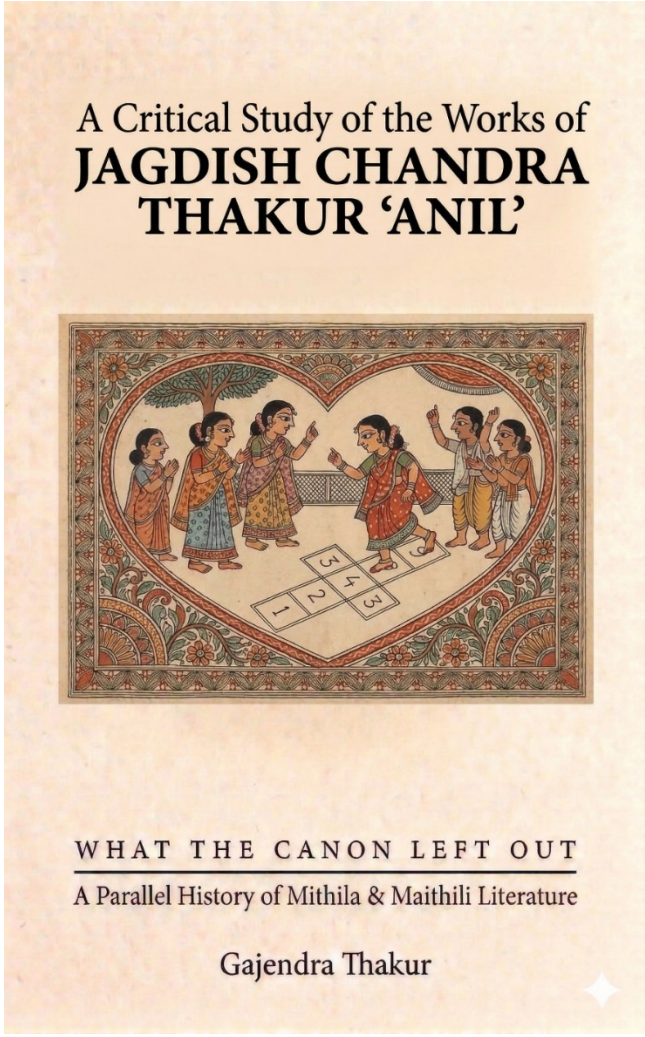


## A Critical Study of the Works of

# JAGDISH CHANDRA THAKUR 'ANIL'

Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil' stands as a significant figure in contemporary Maithili literature — a poet, lyricist, and ghazal-composer whose work spans multiple genres and whose literary career has been intimately intertwined with the Videha movement. Associated with the Videha eJournal (ISSN 2229-547X, www.videha.co.in), the first Maithili fortnightly eJournal established in the early 2000s, 'Anil' represents a generation of writers who embraced both the classical lyrical traditions of Mithila and the democratic, digital-age ethos championed by the Parallel Literature Movement.

His pen name 'Anil' (अनिल — meaning 'wind' or 'air' in Sanskrit) is itself emblematic of the lyric impulse that defines his work: his verse moves with natural grace, carrying the fragrances of Mithila's soil, the emotional landscapes of love and longing, and a political awareness of the marginalised. Videha dedicated its 191st issue (1 December 2015) entirely to 'Anil', an honour that marks his stature in the contemporary Maithili literary world. His books available through Videha's archive at videha.co.in/pothi.htm include a long poem (dīrgha kavitā), two song collections, a ghazal collection, and an autobiography, testifying to his range as a creative artist.

This chapter undertakes a comprehensive study of Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil': his life, literary career, creative philosophy, and the full corpus of his published work. It then applies multiple Indian and Western critical frameworks — rasa theory, dhvani poetics, the Parallel Literature paradigm, postcolonialism, feminist theory, ecocriticism, New Criticism, and narratology — to evaluate and interpret his contribution to Maithili letters.

## 2. Life and Literary Biography

### 2.1 Biographical Profile

Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil' is a Maithili poet, lyricist, and creative writer from the Mithila region. While detailed biographical data in the public domain is sparse — a characteristic shared by many writers within the Videha Parallel Literature Movement, who deliberately resist the canon-forming machinery of the Sahitya Akademi establishment — the contours of his literary identity are traceable through his published work and his sustained association with Videha.

His name 'Jagdish Chandra' carries a classical resonance: Jagdish (Lord of the universe) and Chandra (moon), suggesting a traditional Maithil brahmin or

upper-caste naming convention. Yet his work, particularly his engagement with the Videha democratic literary platform, aligns him with a progressive literary politics that transcends caste boundaries. The adoption of the pen name 'Anil' signals a creative self-fashioning: the wind metaphor evokes both freedom and the capacity to traverse all spaces, high and low, carrying fragrance and carrying dust equally.

## 2.2 Association with the Videha Movement

Videha, established as the first Maithili fortnightly eJournal, represents a revolutionary moment in Maithili literary history. It democratised publication, bypassing the gatekeeping institutions — Sahitya Akademi, university departments, traditional press — that had, in the estimation of its editors, systematically marginalised democratic, folk-rooted, and subaltern literary voices. 'Anil' published children's poetry in Videha from its 50th to 100th issues, indicating an early and sustained engagement with the journal. Three of his children's poems were later anthologised in the Videha Shishu Utsav (Children's Festival) collection, two of which were poems about 'baby child' — a tender, intimate lyric mode that underscores the poet's sensitivity to vulnerability.

The dedication of Videha Issue 191 (1 December 2015) to 'Anil' is a landmark in his literary recognition. These special issues, which Videha has devoted to writers including Ram Bharos Kapari 'Bhramar', Shivshankara Shrinivas, Hitnath Jha, and others, function as the primary site of critical appraisal within the Parallel Literature tradition, substituting for the absence of mainstream critical attention.

Additionally, 'Anil's autobiography Aankhime Chitra Ho Maithili Ker (आँखिमे चित्र हो मैथिली केर — 'May there be pictures of Maithili in my eyes') was being serialised in Videha at its 331st issue, demonstrating ongoing creative productivity and an autobiographical impulse to reflect on a lifetime of literary engagement.

## 2.3 Language and Cultural Context

Maithili, one of the twenty-two scheduled languages of India's Eighth Schedule (recognised in 2003), is the language of the Mithila region — a cultural zone covering parts of Bihar and the Terai of Nepal. It has a literary tradition spanning over a millennium, from the Charyapadas of the Buddhist Siddhas through the foundational poetry of Vidyapati (c. 1352–1448) to a rich modern

literature. 'Anil's work participates in this long tradition while addressing contemporary themes.

The Mithila region carries deep associations with music, lyric poetry, the Madhubani painting tradition, the Tirhuta (Mithilakshara) script, and a complex social world shaped by both Brahminical patriarchy and counter-hegemonic folk traditions. 'Anil's song collections and ghazals are rooted in this cultural landscape — drawing on the imagery of the angana (courtyard), the Ganga river, the seasons — while his long poem and autobiography engage with more critical, contemporary concerns.

## 3. Literary Works: A Descriptive Survey

The following works by Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil' are documented in the Videha archive (videha.co.in/pothi.htm) and related publications:

### 3.1 Dhar Kai Oi Par (धारक ओइ पार) — Long Poem / Dīrgha Kavitā

Dhar Kai Oi Par (Across the Threshold / Beyond the River-bank) is a dīrgha kavitā — a long poem, a genre that in contemporary Maithili, as in Hindi (where practitioners include Nagarjun, Kedar Nath Singh, and Sarveshwar Dayal Saxena), represents an ambition to sustain poetic concentration over extended philosophical, narrative, or lyric terrain. The title is spatially evocative: 'dhar' in Maithili can mean threshold, bank, edge, or stream; 'oi par' means 'on that other side' or 'beyond.' The title thus conjures a liminal poetics — a reaching toward what lies beyond immediate experience, whether that be death, transcendence, the unreachable beloved, or an idealized Mithila.

The dīrgha kavitā as a form draws on both Sanskrit mahākāvya (epic poetry) tradition and Western modernist long poem traditions (Whitman's Song of Myself, Eliot's The Waste Land, Neruda's Canto General). In the Maithili context, it extends the lyric occasion beyond the single moment of a pada or geet into a sustained meditation.

### 3.2 Geet Ganga (गीत गंगा) — Song Collection

Geet Ganga (River of Songs) is a collection of geet — the Maithili lyric song genre that has its roots in the classical padas of Vidyapati, the devotional tradition, and the rich folk music of Mithila. The Ganga (Ganges) as a title

metaphor is significant: rivers are central to Maithili cultural imagination, and the Ganga in particular carries connotations of purification, flow, time, and the interpenetration of the human and the sacred. The choice of 'ganga' — river — rather than a more static 'sangrah' (collection) suggests that 'Anil' conceives of lyric as living, moving, confluent.

'Anil's songs in Videha demonstrate a mastery of the geet form: melodic construction, internal rhyme, imagistic economy, and the capacity to carry emotional weight through apparently simple diction. His published geet draw on the imagery of the angana (inner courtyard), seasonal change (particularly monsoon and spring), and the emotional registers of viraha (separation) and milana (union).

## 3.3 Ghazal Ganga (गजल गंगा) — Ghazal Collection

The ghazal, originally an Arabic and Persian form entering Maithili through Urdu and Hindi literary exchanges, has found remarkable creative expression in contemporary Maithili. Figures like Ashish Anchinhar have developed the theoretical framework of Maithili ghazal prosody (Ghazalsastram), and 'Anil's Ghazal Ganga represents his contribution to this tradition. Published ghazals from Videha Issue 129 (2013) show 'Anil' working in the standard ghazal form with Maithili matla (opening couplet with both hemistichs rhyming), radīf (refrain), qāfiyā (rhyme), and maqta (closing couplet with pen-name).

His ghazal imagery combines classical Maithili lyric tropes — the beloved's face, monsoon evenings, the flame and moth, the sound of water — with contemporary political consciousness: the 'drunk' in the ghazal is sometimes the oppressed subject who has been made 'drunk' on false promises, and the 'wine-house' becomes a political space.

## 3.4 Tora Angana Me (तोरा अंगना मे) — Song Collection

Tora Angana Me (In Your Courtyard) is 'Anil's second documented song collection. The angana (courtyard) is one of the most symbolically charged spaces in Mithila's literary imagination: it is at once a domestic space, a woman's space, a performance space (for folk rituals, paintings, songs), and a liminal space connecting the interior of the house to the world beyond. The repeated use of 'tora' (your / informal second person) establishes intimacy — the poem addresses a beloved, a mother, the Maithili language itself, or the land of Mithila.

Videha holds two versions of this collection: a primary version and a 'mool' (original/source text) version, suggesting that the text underwent editorial evolution or that both print and digital versions were archived. This archival care reflects Videha's commitment to literary preservation.

## 3.5 Aankhime Chitra Ho Maithili Ker (आँखिमे चित्र हो मैथिली केर) — Autobiography

'May There Be Pictures of Maithili in My Eyes' is the title of 'Anil's autobiography, serialised in Videha. The title is a statement of identity and aspiration: the poet desires that his very vision, his inner landscape, be constituted by Maithili — its language, its culture, its people. This is not mere regionalism but a form of what Edward Said called 'belonging': a deliberate affiliation with a language and culture as an act of love and political choice.

Autobiographical writing (ātmakathā) in Maithili is a relatively recent genre, with Shefalikal Varma's Kist Kist Jeevan and Kusum Thakur's Pratyavartan representing significant contributions. 'Anil's autobiography enters this tradition, presumably narrating his life as a Maithili writer across decades that saw the language's struggle for recognition, the rise of the digital publishing revolution, and the emergence of the Parallel Literature Movement.

## 3.6 Children's Poetry in Videha

'Anil's children's poetry — published across Videha issues 50 to 100 and later anthologised in the Videha Shishu Utsav collection — represents a socially significant dimension of his work. Maithili children's literature has historically been underdeveloped relative to Hindi and Bengali, and contributions to this genre carry both pedagogical and cultural preservation importance. Two of his anthologised children's poems focused on the 'baby child', suggesting a tender engagement with infancy and growth as metaphors for both personal memory and cultural continuation.

## 3.7 Ghazals in Videha Issue 129

Issue 129 of Videha (May 2013) contains a sequence of four ghazals by 'Anil'. These include politically charged compositions employing the motif of the road strewn with thorns (ओ रस्तापर कांट छिटैए ओकरा लेल जहल चाही — 'on that road where thorns are scattered, a prison is needed for those who strew them'), indicating that his ghazal practice does not shy from social critique. One of his

ghazal lines invokes Mahishasura (अहिल्याक संताप हरैले' नयनमे गंगाजल चाही — 'to relieve Ahilya's anguish, the Ganga's water is needed in the eyes'), connecting classical mythological reference (Ahilya, the wronged woman of the Ramayana) with contemporary feminist consciousness.

## 4. Critical Analysis Using Indian Literary Theories

### 4.1 Rasa Theory (रसशास्त्र) — Bharatamuni's Nāṭyaśāstra

The Nāṭyaśāstra of Bharatamuni (c. 200 BCE – 200 CE) establishes the theory of rasa — the aesthetic experience of emotion — as the foundation of all literary appreciation. The eight (later nine) rasas — śṛṅgāra (love), hāsya (humour), karuṇa (pathos), raudra (fury), vīra (heroism), bhayānaka (terror), bībhatsa (disgust), adbhuta (wonder), and śānta (serenity) — are not emotions in the ordinary sense but are the transmuted, aestheticised forms of emotion (sthāyibhāva) that arise from the conjunction of vibhāva (stimulus), anubhāva (response), and vyabhicāribhāva (transient emotions).

In 'Anil's song collections (Geet Ganga, Tora Angana Me), śṛṅgāra rasa predominates. The angana of the title functions as the alambana vibhāva (the stimulating object of love): the beloved's courtyard is the space of longing and the space of presence. The Maithili lyric tradition since Vidyapati is overwhelmingly śṛṅgāric, and 'Anil works within and extends this tradition. However, the viraha (separation) mode of śṛṅgāra — which Bharatamuni identifies as ten stages (daśāvasthā) from hope through madness to death — is 'Anil's primary emotional register. His songs are songs of longing: for the beloved, for the homeland, for the language itself.

His ghazals activate karuṇa rasa alongside śṛṅgāra. The image of Ahilya's anguish (Ahilya, turned to stone by her husband Gautama and released only by Rama's touch, is one of Maithili's most resonant feminine suffering figures) in his Videha Issue 129 ghazal generates a complex emotional response where sympathy and indignation commingle — what Abhinavagupta would call the āhlāda (delight) that transcends ordinary empathy.

The dīrgha kavitā Dhar Kai Oi Par potentially activates multiple rasas across its extended form — beginning perhaps in adbhuta (wonder at threshold

experience), moving through śṛṅgāra (love), karuṇa (pathos), and arriving at śānta (serenity beyond duality). This multi-rasa arc, what the rhetoricians termed rasabhāva-parampara, would make it a work of considerable aesthetic complexity.

## 4.2 Dhvani Theory (ध्वनि) — Ānandavardhana's Dhvanyāloka

Ānandavardhana's Dhvanyāloka (c. 850 CE) articulates the theory of dhvani — resonance or suggestion — as the supreme principle of poetic excellence. Where vyañjanā (suggestion) outperforms abhidhā (denotation) and lakṣaṇā (indication), the poem achieves its highest power. The resonant meaning — the dhvani — is what vibrates in the reader's consciousness after the words have been read, like the sound that lingers after a bell is struck.

'Anil's title Tora Angana Me is a masterpiece of dhvani. The word 'angana' (courtyard) resonates beyond its literal denotation. In Maithili cultural memory, the angana is: the site of the Kohbar painting (drawn at marriage); the space where women sing the sohar (birth songs) and saman (wedding songs); the threshold between domestic interior and public exterior; the space of childhood memory; and — in the broader literary imagination — the symbol of the language's own interior landscape. 'In your courtyard' thus suggests simultaneously: I am in the space of the beloved; I am in the space of Maithili culture; I am in the space of memory; I am at home.

Similarly, the autobiography's title Aankhime Chitra Ho Maithili Ker deploys dhvani superbly. 'Chitra' means both 'picture/image' and (in a classical secondary sense) the Madhubani paintings for which Mithila is globally renowned. 'Aankhime' (in the eyes) evokes the act of seeing, of visionary experience, and also the idea that the beloved's image is lodged in the lover's eyes (a standard trope from the Vidyapati tradition). The title thus says simultaneously: 'May my eyes see Maithili'; 'May Maithili's image be inscribed in my eyes as Madhubani painting is inscribed on walls'; and 'May I carry within my vision the beloved that Maithili is to me.'

## 4.3 Vakrokti Theory — Kuntaka's Vakroktijīvita

Kuntaka's Vakroktijīvita (c. 950 CE) proposes vakrokti (oblique/striking expression) as the life-force of poetry. Where ordinary language proceeds straightforwardly, poetic language swerves — it makes the familiar strange, the simple complex, the transparent opaque. This obliquity is not obscurity but a

heightened expressiveness that opens language to multiple meanings simultaneously.

'Anil's ghazal practice is fundamentally vakroktic. The ghazal form itself, with its detached couplets (ash'ār) each complete in itself yet connected through the radīf-qāfiyā framework, demands oblique meaning-making. The maqta's use of the pen-name 'Anil' in the closing couplet creates a vakrokti where the poet speaks of himself in the third person, a self-distancing that paradoxically intensifies self-expression. His political imagery — prisons for those who strew thorns, the need for Ganga-water in the eyes — operates through vakrokti: the literal image is social critique; the suggested image is spiritual aspiration.

## 4.4 Aucitya Theory — Kshemendra's Aucityavicāracarcā

Kshemendra (c. 1050 CE) argued that aucitya (propriety, fittingness, contextual appropriateness) was the supreme literary virtue. A poem achieves greatness when every element — word, image, emotion, metre, figure — is exactly right for its context. Aucitya does not mean correctness by rule but rightness by judgment.

'Anil's choice of genre is itself an exercise in aucitya. He writes geet for the beloved and for the homeland — a form with deep cultural roots in Mithila's performative traditions. He writes ghazal for social-political themes and for complex emotion — a form historically suited to urban sophistication and emotional nuance. He writes dīrgha kavitā for philosophical meditation. Each genre is fitting for its subject matter. His use of the Ganga metaphor for both song collection and ghazal collection is aucita (appropriate): both forms flow, both accumulate meaning as they move, both are nourishing.

## 4.5 The Parallel Literature Movement Framework

The Parallel Literature Movement (samānāntar sāhitya āndolan), as theorised through the Videha platform, challenges the hegemony of the Sahitya Akademi canon and its preference for works compliant with standard literary prestige markers. The Parallel Literature Movement argues for a democratic literary sphere that includes folk forms, oral traditions, digital publications, subaltern voices, and regional writers who have been systematically excluded from the mainstream.

'Anil's association with Videha places him squarely within this tradition. His children's poetry — a genre typically undervalued by the literary establishment — his serialised autobiography, and his ghazals all represent modes of writing

that the Parallel Literature framework validates and promotes. The very fact that his primary archive is digital and free-to-access at videha.co.in embodies the democratic-access philosophy of the movement.

From this framework, 'Anil's most significant literary act is his sustained lyric engagement with the Maithili language itself as a beloved — the autobiography's title declares the language the object of the poet's deepest vision. This mirrors the movement's broader politics of linguistic love: where the establishment treats Maithili as a minor regional language, the Videha writers treat it as the supreme medium of their interior lives.

## 5. Critical Analysis Using Western Literary Theories

### 5.1 New Criticism: Organic Unity and Irony

New Criticism, developed by I.A. Richards, Cleanth Brooks, W.K. Wimsatt, and others, demands close reading of the literary text as a self-sufficient artefact. Key concepts include organic unity (all elements of the poem cohere into a unified whole), irony (the poem holds contradictions in tension), paradox, and ambiguity as virtues.

Applied to 'Anil's ghazal form, New Criticism reveals productive tensions. The ghazal is generically anti-organic: its couplets are deliberately independent, resisting the smooth narrative flow of Western lyric poetry. Yet within each sher (couplet), there is intense organic coherence. The apparent paradox — a form that is fragmented at the macro level but unified at the micro level — is itself an instance of the New Critical virtue of holding contradictions in tension. Each sher of 'Anil's ghazals is a poem complete in itself; the collection as a whole is a mosaic.

The title Dhar Kai Oi Par exhibits New Critical paradox: a 'threshold' (dhar) is defined by what it divides, yet the poem aspires to go 'beyond' (oi par) — to transcend the very boundary that defines the poem's situation. The poem is thus simultaneously about limitation and transgression.

### 5.2 Structuralism: Binary Oppositions and Literary Systems

Structuralist literary theory, derived from Saussure's linguistics and developed by Lévi-Strauss, Roland Barthes, and Tzvetan Todorov, analyses literature in

terms of underlying structures, binary oppositions, and the system of signs through which meaning is produced.

In 'Anil's song collections, a fundamental binary opposition operates: angana (interior/domestic/feminine) versus the world outside (exterior/public/masculine). Tora Angana Me positions the lyric subject outside the beloved's courtyard, looking in — the reverse of the patriarchal domestic arrangement in which women are confined to the angana. This structural inversion carries a feminist charge: the poem expresses the male lover's longing to enter the feminine interior space, recognising it as the locus of value.

The title Geet Ganga employs the structuralist binary of river/land — the Ganga as the flowing, continuous, uncontainable element that resists being fixed, versus the settled bank of tradition. 'Anil's songs are the river, not the bank; they carry but do not remain. This structural metaphor encodes his poetic philosophy: song as movement, not monument.

## 5.3 Postcolonial Theory

Postcolonial theory, particularly the work of Frantz Fanon, Edward Said, Homi Bhabha, and Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak, addresses the cultural, psychological, and political dimensions of colonial and postcolonial experience. In the Indian regional context, postcolonial theory illuminates the double colonialism experienced by minority-language writers: colonial dispossession by British imperialism and continued postcolonial marginalisation by the Hindi-dominant national culture.

'Anil's autobiography, with its title's declaration that Maithili should fill his eyes, is a postcolonial act of what Fanon called 're-humanisation': the recovery of selfhood through the reclamation of indigenous language and culture. For a Maithili writer in Bihar, where Hindi dominates education, media, and government, writing in Maithili is a political choice — an insistence on speaking in one's own tongue rather than the tongue of the dominant power.

Homi Bhabha's concept of the 'third space' — the hybrid, liminal space between colonial and indigenous cultures where new meanings are produced — is useful for understanding 'Anil's ghazal practice. The Maithili ghazal occupies a third space: it borrows the form of Arabic-Persian-Urdu literary culture (itself a symbol of a different colonialism — the Mughal imperial culture), translates it into the Maithili linguistic and cultural context, and produces something new. The ghazal in Maithili is neither purely Urdu-derivative nor purely Maithili-

indigenous; it is a hybrid form that generates meanings neither language alone could produce.

Said's concept of 'imaginative geographies' — the way cultures construct spatial maps of self and other — illuminates the recurrent river imagery in 'Anil's titles. The Ganga and the unnamed 'dhar' (river-bank/threshold) in his titles construct a Maithili imaginative geography: a landscape defined by rivers, by boundaries, by the tension between here and there, belonging and longing.

## 5.4 Feminist Theory

Feminist literary theory — from Virginia Woolf through Simone de Beauvoir, Judith Butler, and the Indian feminist tradition represented by Susie Tharu, K. Lalita, and Uma Chakravarti — analyses literature for its representation of women, its inscription of gender ideology, and its potential for feminist counter-discourse.

'Anil's invocation of Ahilya in his Videha Issue 129 ghazal is a significant feminist gesture. Ahilya's story in the Ramayana tradition — a woman punished (turned to stone) for an act of adultery that she either consented to or was deceived into — has been read both as a story of male vengeance and as a story of female resilience (her 'stone' state as a form of resistance, her liberation by Rama as a type of feminist redemption). 'Anil's ghazal line 'Ahilya's anguish must be relieved — Ganga-water is needed in the eyes' reads Ahilya's story through karuṇā (compassion) rather than through judgement, positioning the poet in solidarity with the wronged woman.

The repeated angana imagery in Tora Angana Me can be read through feminist spatial theory. The angana is simultaneously a space of women's confinement and a space of women's power: it is where women create Madhubani paintings, sing Maithili songs, and conduct rituals that sustain cultural memory. By making the angana the central symbol of his lyric, 'Anil acknowledges the angana as the centre of cultural production — a feminist revaluation of domestic space.

## 5.5 Ecocriticism

Ecocriticism, developed in the 1990s through the work of Lawrence Buell, Cheryl Glotfelty, and Indian ecocritics like Ranjan Ghosh, examines the representation of the natural world in literature and the ethical implications of those representations. In the Indian context, ecocriticism intersects with political ecology: environmental degradation in Mithila (flooding,

deforestation, agrarian crisis) is inseparable from questions of caste, poverty, and state neglect.

'Anil's river imagery — Geet Ganga, Ghazal Ganga, Dhar Kai Oi Par — can be read ecocritically. The Ganga is not a neutral or static symbol; it is a river under ecological threat. Bihar and the Mithila region are particularly vulnerable to flooding, and the rivers of Mithila — Kosi, Bagmati, Kamla, and the Ganga itself — have been both sources of life and agents of devastation. When 'Anil names his song collection 'Geet Ganga', he inscribes the river into his literary identity in a way that carries this ecological weight. Song is identified with a river that is simultaneously sacred and endangered.

The image of Ahilya's need for 'Ganga-water in the eyes' also carries an ecocritical resonance: to heal the wronged woman, the poet reaches for the river — nature as healer, water as restorative force. This gestures toward an ecology of care that connects human suffering and natural resources.

## 5.6 Reader-Response Theory

Reader-response theory, associated with Wolfgang Iser, Stanley Fish, and Hans Robert Jauss, shifts critical attention from the text itself to the interaction between text and reader. Iser's concept of 'implied reader', Jauss's 'horizon of expectations', and Fish's 'interpretive communities' are useful analytical tools.

'Anil's work implies multiple, overlapping audiences. His children's poetry in Videha implies a young Maithili-literate audience learning to love their language through accessible, playful verse. His geet imply a musically literate audience familiar with the Maithili lyric tradition — an audience that will hear the melodic possibilities of his lines. His ghazals imply an audience conversant with ghazal conventions (radīf, qāfiyā, maqta) who can appreciate his deployment and creative modification of the form. His autobiography implies the broadest audience — any Maithili reader interested in the personal history of a writer's engagement with the language.

Jauss's 'horizon of expectations' is particularly illuminating. A reader approaching 'Anil's Ghazal Ganga with expectations formed by the Urdu ghazal tradition (Mir, Ghalib, Faiz) will find both familiar and unfamiliar: familiar formal architecture, unfamiliar linguistic material (Maithili sounds, lexicon, cultural references). This productive defamiliarisation — what Jauss calls the 'aesthetic distance' between existing horizon and new work — is central to the pleasure and significance of 'Anil's ghazal practice.

### 5.7 Psychoanalytic Criticism

Psychoanalytic literary criticism, drawing on Freud's concepts of the unconscious and repression, Lacan's theory of language and desire, and object-relations theory, reads literary texts as expressions of unconscious dynamics.

The recurrent 'other shore' (oi par) imagery in Dhar Kai Oi Par is amenable to psychoanalytic reading. Lacan's concept of the objet petit a — the unattainable object-cause of desire, the 'more-than-real' thing that cannot be possessed because possessing it would dissolve desire itself — illuminates the poem's structure. The 'other shore' is always already beyond: to cross the threshold (dhar) would be to lose the very desire that animates the crossing. The poem is thus a meditation on desire as structured absence.

'Anil's autobiography, with its title's declaration that 'Maithili' should be the picture in his eyes, can be read as an account of literary sublimation: the displacement of personal desire onto the language and culture of Mithila. Freud's concept of sublimation — the transformation of libidinal energy into cultural production — finds a literary instance in the writer who channels longing into love of language.

### 5.8 Narratology and Genre Theory

Narratology (Gérard Genette, Roland Barthes, Mieke Bal) analyses the structures of narrative. Applied to 'Anil's autobiography, it illuminates his use of analepsis (flashback), prolepsis (anticipation), and the complex relationship between story-time (the life narrated) and discourse-time (the narrating act).

The title Aankhime Chitra Ho Maithili Ker establishes the autobiography as a genre of visual narration: the self is constructed through what the eyes have seen. This is a form of homodiegetic narration (the narrator is the protagonist) with a retrospective perspective. The autobiography's serialisation in Videha — an eJournal published fortnightly — means that it was produced in instalments, creating a diachronic narrative experience for readers who followed it across issues. This serialisation links the autobiography to a tradition going back to Victorian serial fiction (Dickens, Thackeray) and forward to contemporary digital narrative practice.

## 6. Synthesis: 'Anil's Place in Maithili Literature

Reading 'Anil's work through these multiple critical lenses reveals a writer of considerable range, depth, and cultural significance. Several defining characteristics emerge:

### 6.1 The Lyric Core

'Anil is fundamentally a lyric poet. Whether writing geet, ghazal, or dīrgha kavitā, his primary mode is lyric: the expression of heightened emotional experience through musical language. This aligns him with the central tradition of Maithili literature since Vidyapati, which has always privileged the musical word. His contribution to this tradition is the introduction of the social-political charge — particularly visible in his ghazals — that has characterised the post-Independence Maithili lyric.

### 6.2 The Multilingual Cultural Position

Writing in Maithili for a Videha readership that is often bilingual (Maithili-Hindi) or trilingual (adding English or Nepali), 'Anil occupies a multilingual cultural position. The ghazal form itself is a bridge form: its Urdu-Persian origins give Maithili-speaking readers a form they may recognise from Hindi-Urdu cultural contexts, while its Maithili content asserts linguistic distinctiveness. This bridge function — making Maithili poetry accessible to readers who might otherwise default to Hindi literary forms — is a significant cultural contribution.

### 6.3 The Democratic Digital Aesthetic

The fact that 'Anil's archive is primarily digital — housed at videha.co.in, freely downloadable, read across the globe by the Maithili diaspora in India, Nepal, and beyond — gives his work a democratic accessibility that print publication in a minority language could never achieve. This digital aesthetic — light, accessible, non-monumental — suits his lyric mode. A song wants to be sung and heard, not preserved behind glass.

### 6.4 The Autobiographical Impulse

The autobiography Aankhime Chitra Ho Maithili Ker is perhaps his most ambitious project: a sustained act of literary self-examination and cultural testimony. In documenting his life as a Maithili writer, 'Anil bears witness not only to personal experience but to the history of the Maithili language's survival, struggle, and digital renaissance in the early twenty-first century.

## 7. Conclusion

Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil' is a distinctive voice in contemporary Maithili literature: a lyric poet who deploys the traditional forms of geet and ghazal with both technical mastery and creative independence, a dīrgha kavitā practitioner engaged with philosophical and existential themes, and an autobiographer documenting a life devoted to the Maithili language and the Mithila cultural heritage.

His work embodies the central paradox of the Parallel Literature Movement: it is rooted in classical tradition (Vidyapati's lyric inheritance, the Sanskrit rasa aesthetic, the Mithila folk tradition) while being simultaneously forward-looking, politically conscious, and digitally democratised. The critical frameworks applied here — rasa theory, dhvani poetics, Parallel Literature, postcolonialism, feminism, ecocriticism, reader-response, psychoanalysis, and narratology — all yield productive insights, confirming the multi-layered richness of his texts.

The dedication of Videha Issue 191 to 'Anil' is a testament to his significance within the community of Maithili writers that Videha represents. As the Maithili language continues its struggle for visibility and recognition in the twenty-first century — on digital platforms, in Sahitya Akademi award lists, in school curricula, in the global Maithili diaspora — the work of writers like 'Anil' constitutes the living proof that the language's lyric heart continues to beat with full force.

Further research on 'Anil's work would benefit from textual analysis of the full manuscripts of Dhar Kai Oi Par, Geet Ganga, Ghazal Ganga, and Tora Angana Me (available at videha.co.in/pothi.htm), interviews with the author, and systematic comparison with other contemporary Maithili lyric poets including Ram Bharos Kapari 'Bhramar', Shivshankara Shrinivas, and younger Videha contributors. Such research would establish 'Anil's precise place in the genealogy of the Maithili lyric and the broader South Asian poetic tradition.

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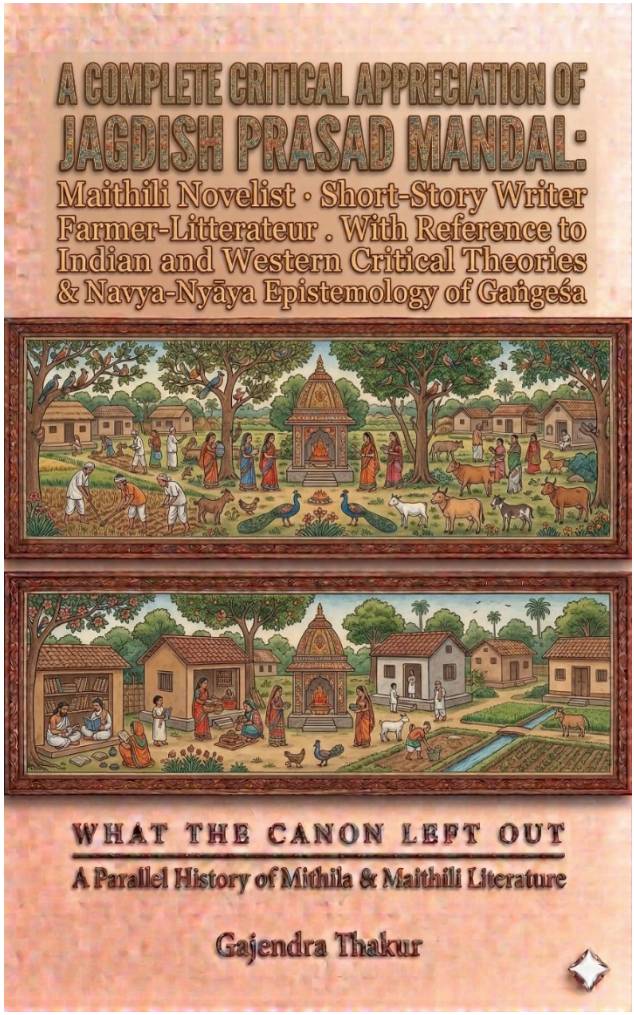


# A COMPLETE CRITICAL APPRECIATION OF

# JAGDISH PRASAD MANDAL

*Maithili Novelist · Short-Story Writer · Farmer-Litterateur*

*With Reference to Indian and Western Critical Theories, & Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa*

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## I. BIOGRAPHICAL INTRODUCTION: THE FARMER-LITTERATEUR

Jagdish Prasad Mandal (born c. 1952, Madhubani District, Bihar) stands as one of the most consequential voices in contemporary Maithili literature—a writer whose social location as a farmer from the Other Backward Class (OBC) community fundamentally shaped both the content and form of his literary production. A postgraduate in Hindi and Political Science, Mandal chose to remain rooted in agricultural life even as he built an extensive literary career, embodying the Gramscian ideal of an organic intellectual who speaks from within the community rather than above it.

Mandal's background in Madhubani—the heartland of Mithila—gave him intimate access to the vernacular landscape, folk traditions, agricultural cycles, and caste tensions that form the texture of his writing. Unlike the dominant stream of Maithili letters, long shaped by Maithil Brahmin scholarly culture centred on Darbhanga, Mandal represents the subaltern voice that Gajendra Thakur's Videha movement—the first Maithili fortnightly e-journal (ISSN 2229-547X, est. 2000)—worked to bring into literary visibility.

Gajendra Thakur has noted that until 2021, the Sahitya Akademi's Maithili awards had been distributed as follows: Maithil Brahmins 42 times, Kayasthas 6 times, Rajputs 3 times, and Others zero times. Mandal's Sahitya Akademi Award for 2021 for his novel Pangu (Pallavi Prakashan, Nirmali, 2018) thus represents not only a personal honour but a structural rupture in the literary field—the first time a writer from a non-upper-caste farming community received this recognition in Maithili.

Dr. Baidyanath Choudhary Baiju, General Secretary of Vidyapati Seva Sansthan, observed that Mandal 'has set an example by achieving unprecedented success in the field of literature while being active in the field of vegetable production.' This union of agrarian labour and literary creation is not incidental but constitutive of Mandal's entire aesthetic project.

## II. SURVEY OF WORKS: NOVELS, SHORT STORIES, AND OTHER WRITINGS

### 2.1 Novels

Mandal's novelistic output is remarkable for its sustained focus on the social fabric of Mithila's agrarian communities. His major novels include:

**Gamak Jingi ('Life of the Village'):** His most celebrated early novel-cycle dealing with rural Maithili life in its quotidian complexity—farming rhythms,

familial bonds, caste conflicts, and the quiet dignity of the labouring classes. The title itself announces the scope: the life (jingi) of a village (gamak) as a totality.

**Pangu (2018, Pallavi Prakashan, Nirmali):** Winner of the Sahitya Akademi Award 2021. The Maithili word pangu denotes lameness, both physical and social. The novel deploys physical disability as an extended metaphor for the social immobility imposed by caste, class, and systemic neglect upon ordinary people. It is Mandal's most formally accomplished work, integrating realist social documentation with subtle symbolist technique.

**Ijjat Gama Ijjat Banchelo ('Honour Lost, Honour Saved'):** A novel examining the politics of honour (ijjat) in Maithili village culture—how it functions as a tool of social control, particularly upon women and those of lower social rank.

### 2.2 Short Stories

Mandal's short stories—many published in Videha and in print collections—are widely regarded as his laboratory for technique. They are characterised by an ear for vernacular Maithili idiom, tight narrative economy, and an unflinching gaze at caste violence, agricultural distress, and the inner lives of women and OBC communities. Critics have placed his stories within the tradition that Outlook India's kathakar Ashok identified as constituting a 'larger community integrated with Maithili literature through their works'—alongside Ram Vilas Sahu and Umesh Mandal.

### 2.3 Literary Activism and the Videha Connection

Mandal has been an active contributor to Videha (www.videha.co.in), Gajendra Thakur's pioneering Maithili e-journal, which began as 'Bhalsarik Gachh' (the first Maithili blog) in 2000 and became Videha from 1 January 2008. This connection is significant: Videha explicitly positioned itself as an instrument of 'parallel literature' against the casteist mainstream literary establishment, and Mandal's prolific contributions to it placed him at the heart of this democratising movement in Maithili letters.

## III. THEMATIC AND IDEOLOGICAL ANALYSIS

### 3.1 The Subaltern and the Village as Literary Universe

Mandal's central achievement is the elevation of the non-Brahmin Maithili village to the status of a fully realised literary world. In contrast to earlier Maithili fiction that often filtered rural life through upper-caste sensibility (as in Harimohan Jha's celebrated satire Khattar Kakak Tarang, which targets

Brahmin orthodoxy but retains an insider's perspective), Mandal writes from the position of those who worked the land. His gamak—village—is not a picturesque backdrop but a living social organism with its own epistemology, conflicts, and poetry.

### 3.2 Caste, Class, and the Disabled Body

Pangu most explicitly engages the intersection of bodily disability and social disadvantage. The protagonist's physical lameness becomes a site for exploring how Maithili society marks certain bodies as unproductive, burdensome, and socially redundant—mirroring the structural exclusion of entire communities. This move connects Mandal to the broader tradition of Dalit and OBC literature across Indian languages, while remaining specific to the Maithili context. Disability Studies scholars in the line of Rosemarie Garland-Thomson's 'misfits' framework find a ready application here: Mandal's pangu figure does not 'fit' the social environment not because of bodily deficit but because the environment is built to exclude.

### 3.3 Women, Honour, and the Domestic Sphere

Mandal's narratives consistently interrogate the gendered architecture of Maithili village honour culture. In Ijjat Gama Ijjat Banchelo, the concept of ijjat is revealed as a patriarchal mechanism that polices women's bodies and choices while simultaneously being invoked to justify social violence. This critical stance aligns Mandal with the feminist strands visible in contemporary Maithili fiction by Shefalika Verma (Naagfans), Usha Kiran Khan (Bhamati), and Vibha Rani.

### 3.4 Agricultural Life and the Crisis of the Maithili Peasant

Unlike the urbanised or cosmopolitan concerns of much Indian literary modernism, Mandal's work insists on the specificity of agricultural crisis—floods, land tenure, moneylending, crop failure—as lived experience and literary subject. This makes him a significant figure in what might be called 'agri-realism' in Indian vernacular literatures, comparable to Phanishwar Nath Renu's Maila Aanchal (Hindi, 1954) in its sociological density.

## IV. CRITICAL APPRECIATION: WESTERN LITERARY THEORIES

### 4.1 Realism and Social Realism

Measured against the tradition of European literary realism—Balzac's 'total social fact', Lukács's demand for typicality, and the English social novel from George Eliot to Hardy—Mandal emerges as a thoroughgoing realist committed to the faithful representation of the Maithili social formation. Like

Lukács's ideal of the realist novel (The Theory of the Novel, 1916; Studies in European Realism, 1950), Mandal's fiction seeks to capture the totality of social relations through the lives of representative individuals. His village characters are not idealisations but what Lukács called 'typical' figures—individuals in whom the contradictions of their historical moment crystallise.

Georg Lukács distinguished between critical realism and socialist realism on the basis of the author's relationship to historical consciousness. Mandal's work occupies an intermediate but distinctive position: it is not programmatically socialist in the Zhdanovist sense, yet it maintains a sustained critical consciousness of caste and class as historical formations—closer, perhaps, to the 'critical realism' Lukács admired in Balzac than to the tendentiousness of socialist realism.

### 4.2 Postcolonial Theory: Subaltern Studies and Vernacular Literature

Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's foundational question—'Can the subaltern speak?' (1988)—acquires a precise inflection in Mandal's case. Mandal is the subaltern who speaks, in the language of the subaltern community (Maithili), to and about that community. This is not the metropolitan intellectual 'giving voice' to the marginalised but a writer located within the subaltern social structure who has developed the literary tools to represent that structure from within. Homi Bhabha's concept of the 'third space'—the liminal zone of cultural negotiation (The Location of Culture, 1994)—applies to Mandal's position between the oral folk culture of Mithila's peasant communities and the literary canon of Maithili writing.

Ranajit Guha's Subaltern Studies framework, particularly the concept of 'the prose of counter-insurgency', is germane here. Mandal's fiction constructs what might be called the 'prose of counter-exclusion': a literary discourse that makes visible the humanity, interiority, and social complexity of communities systematically excluded from Maithili literary representation.

### 4.3 Narrative Theory: Point of View and Free Indirect Discourse

Wayne Booth's concept of the 'implied author' (The Rhetoric of Fiction, 1961) and Gérard Genette's narratological categories (Narrative Discourse, 1972) illuminate Mandal's technique. His third-person narrators typically maintain what Genette calls 'internal focalisation'—the narrative perspective closely aligned with the experiential world of the protagonist, giving readers intimate access to consciousness without the melodrama of first-person confession. His use of free indirect discourse—narrating a character's thoughts through the narrator's voice without explicit quotation marks—permits a subtle

empathy that is politically significant: it refuses the 'othering' of OBC and peasant characters that characterised much earlier Maithili fiction.

### 4.4 Structuralism, Semiotics, and the Village Sign-System

Ferdinand de Saussure's distinction between langue (the linguistic system) and parole (individual speech acts) finds a literary analogue in Mandal's relationship to Maithili: he draws on the deep system of Maithili vernacular expression (its idioms, proverbs, folk-tale structures) while creating highly individualised narrative speech acts (parole). Roland Barthes's concept of mythologies—the way cultural signs naturalise historical constructions—illuminates Mandal's critical engagement with the mythology of ijjat (honour): Pangu and Ijjat Gama Ijjat Banchelo demythologise honour as a naturalised social good, revealing it as a constructed and contested sign in a power-laden semiotic field.

### 4.5 Mikhail Bakhtin: Heteroglossia and the Polyphonic Novel

Bakhtin's concept of heteroglossia (raznorechie)—the coexistence of multiple social voices and speech registers within a single novelistic text (The Dialogic Imagination, 1981)—is particularly apt for Mandal's work. His novels do not impose a monologic authorial voice but allow the multiple, competing speech registers of Maithili village life—the landlord's officiousness, the labourer's oblique resistance, the woman's constrained expression, the child's unguarded perception—to create meaning dialogically. This polyphonic structure is both aesthetically innovative and politically significant: it refuses the hierarchisation of voices that characterised the socially conservative strand of Maithili fiction.

### 4.6 Magic Realism and Folk-Narrative Devices

Maithili kathakar Ashok, in an interview with Outlook India (2024), noted that contemporary Maithili fiction uses 'folk-narrative world' resources —'snakes, dismembered thumb, etc.'—in ways that approximate magic realism, to 'reveal the mystery of characters of complicated people.' While Mandal is primarily a social realist, his deployment of folk symbolism in certain stories draws on this tradition. Gabriel García Márquez's magic realism was itself rooted in the oral traditions of Latin American peasant communities; Mandal's selective use of Maithili folk symbolism similarly roots his literary technique in a vernacular cosmology.

## V. CRITICAL APPRECIATION: INDIAN AESTHETICS, NĀṬYAŚĀSTRA, AND RASA THEORY

### 5.1 Bharata's Nāṭyaśāstra: Rasa and Its Application to Fiction

Bharata Muni's Nāṭyaśāstra (c. 200 BCE–200 CE)—the foundational text of Indian aesthetics—defines rasa as the essential emotive flavour evoked by a work of art through the combination of vibhāva (stimulus), anubhāva (response), and vyabhicāri-bhāva (transitory emotions). While Bharata's treatise focuses on drama (nāṭya), the rasa theory was extended to all literary forms by subsequent theorists including Ānandavardhana and Abhinavagupta.

Mandal's primary rasa is karuṇa (the pathetic/compassionate), the rasa arising from sorrow and suffering, whose permanent emotion (sthāyibhāva) is śoka (grief). The pangu protagonist of his Akademi-winning novel evokes this rasa with sustained power: the vibhāva are the social structures that disable and exclude; the anubhāva are the protagonist's constrained movements through a world not built for him; the vyabhicāri-bhāva include the transitory emotions of helplessness, occasional joy, resignation, and unexpected solidarity. The reader's aesthetic experience of karuṇa is not mere pity but the purification (viśrānti) that Abhinavagupta describes as the hallmark of fully realised rasa.

Alongside karuṇa, Mandal's work activates vīra rasa (the heroic), understood not in the martial sense but in the sense of moral courage—the quiet heroism of the labouring person who persists with dignity under unjust conditions. This 'subaltern vīra' is a significant innovation: Bharata's vīra rasa was associated with warrior-kings (kṣatriya heroism), but Mandal recasts it as the heroism of the peasant who refuses to be fully defeated.

### 5.2 Dhvani (Resonance) Theory: Ānandavardhana and Abhinavagupta

Ānandavardhana's Dhvanyāloka (c. 850 CE) proposes that the highest literary achievement consists not in what is directly stated (vācya) but in what is suggested (dhvani)—the resonant, unstated meaning that the cultivated reader intuits. Abhinavagupta's commentary Locana deepens this theory by connecting dhvani to the universal aesthetic consciousness (sādhāraṇīkaraṇa—generalisation of emotion from individual to universal).

Mandal's narrative technique is rich in dhvani. In Pangu, the protagonist's physical disability suggests—without ever stating directly—the social paralysis of an entire class. The novel's silences, its reticences, its refusal to editorialise, generate a dhvani of structural injustice more powerful than any explicit polemic. This technique connects Mandal to the best traditions of Indian literary suggestiveness, from Kālidāsa's āranyas to the subliminal social critique in Premchand's Godan.

### 5.3 Alaṃkāra Tradition: Figurative Language in Mandal's Prose

The Sanskrit alaṃkāra (ornament/figure) tradition, as codified by Daṇḍin (Kāvyādarśa, c. 7th century CE) and Mammaṭa (Kāvyaprakāśa, c. 11th century CE), identifies upamā (simile), rūpaka (metaphor), and vyājastuti (ironic praise) as principal poetic figures. Mandal's prose deploys these with remarkable economy. His similes are drawn from the agricultural world—the simile of the bullock yoked to the grinding stone for the circular repetition of poverty; the rūpaka of the withered crop for the stunted life of the disabled peasant. These figures are not decorative but functional: they build the cognitive and emotional architecture of meaning.

### 5.4 Nāṭyaśāstra's Social Registers (Pravṛtti) and Mandal's Language Politics

Bharata's Nāṭyaśāstra specifies that different social classes should speak different varieties of language: Sanskrit for kings and heroes, Prakrit for women and lesser characters, Apabhraṃśa for low-caste characters. This linguistic hierarchy, which encoded social stratification within the dramatic text itself, has been a contested legacy. Some conservative Maithili dramatists, as Gajendra Thakur's Parallel History of Maithili Literature documents, tried to use Nāṭyaśāstra's authority to justify derogatory representation of lower-caste communities in Maithili drama. Mandal's fiction performs a radical inversion: the vernacular Maithili of the peasant and OBC community is the literary standard, the language of dignity and interiority, while the Sanskrit-inflected high register associated with Brahmin culture appears as one social dialect among others.

## VI. NAVYA-NYĀYA EPISTEMOLOGY OF GAṄGEŚA UPĀDHYĀYA APPLIED TO MANDAL'S PROSE

### 6.1 Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya and the Navya-Nyāya School

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (fl. 13th–14th century CE, Mithila) was the founder of Navya-Nyāya (New Logic), the most technically sophisticated school of Indian epistemology and logic, enshrined in his magnum opus Tattvacintāmaṇi ('The Wish-Fulfilling Gem of Truth'). The Navya-Nyāya school developed rigorous tools for the analysis of knowledge (jñāna), valid cognition (pramā), and the conditions under which a proposition may be regarded as true. Gaṅgeśa's own social biography is instructive: Videha's Parallel History documents, with reference to panji (genealogical) records, that Gaṅgeśa married a woman of artisan (charmakāriṇī) caste and was himself 'of inferior social status' in the casteist hierarchy of medieval Mithila—a fact suppressed by conservative Maithili scholars but recovered by Gajendra Thakur. Thus

Gaṅgeśa and Mandal share a structural position: both produced foundational intellectual work from within communities marginalised by the dominant Brahmin culture of Mithila.

### 6.2 Navya-Nyāya Analytical Categories Applied to Mandal's Narrative

Navya-Nyāya distinguishes between viśeṣya (the qualified entity/substrate), viśeṣaṇa (the qualifier/property), and their relation (saṃbandha). Applied as a critical methodology to Mandal's fiction, this tripartite analytical structure illuminates his narrative technique:

**Viśeṣya (Substrate):** The social body of the Maithili village—its structures of caste, kinship, and agricultural economy—functions as the permanent substrate (ādhāra) of Mandal's narrative world.

**Viśeṣaṇa (Qualifier):** Individual characters and events function as qualifiers that specify and particularise the general substrate. In Pangu, the protagonist's disability is the viśeṣaṇa that qualifies the general substrate of caste-mediated social exclusion, making its operations visible in a specific instance.

**Saṃbandha (Relation):** The relationship between character and social structure is not one of simple causation (as in naturalist fiction) but of complex, multi-directional conditioning. Navya-Nyāya's attention to different types of relational categories (tādātmya—identity, samavāya—inherence, saṃyoga—conjunction) helps articulate the varied ways in which Mandal's characters are both formed by and resist their social conditioning.

### 6.3 Pramāṇa (Valid Knowledge) and Literary Truth

Navya-Nyāya identifies four pramāṇas (sources of valid knowledge): pratyakṣa (perception), anumāna (inference), upamāna (analogy/comparison), and śabda (verbal testimony). Mandal's literary practice can be read through this epistemological framework. His realism rests on pratyakṣa—the authority of direct experience of agricultural Maithili life; his structural critique employs anumāna—reasoning from observed particulars to general social structures; his figurative language (similes of the grinding stone, the withered crop) deploys upamāna; and his engagement with Maithili oral and folk tradition draws on śabda—the knowledge preserved in collective linguistic memory.

### 6.4 Vyāpti (Universal Concomitance) and the Novel's Claim to Truth

Navya-Nyāya's concept of vyāpti—universal concomitance, the co-occurrence of a property (sādhya) with its reason (hetu) in all instances—underpins the logical validity of inferences. Applied critically, vyāpti speaks to the question of whether Mandal's fictional particulars support general truths

about Maithili social life. The novel Pangu achieves vyāpti when the particular story of one disabled peasant generates the universal recognition of structural social disability: readers infer from the specific case a general principle about how Maithili society constructs and naturalises exclusion. This movement from particular to universal—from the viśeṣa to the sāmānya—is the hallmark of both Navya-Nyāya inference and the realist novel at its best.

## VII. COMPARATIVE STUDY: MANDAL AMONG MAITHILI WRITERS

### 7.1 Mandal and Harimohan Jha (1908–1984): The Two Faces of Maithili Social Critique

Harimohan Jha's Khattar Kakak Tarang (serialised from 1940s) is the foundational text of social-satirical Maithili prose. Written from an upper-caste insider's perspective, it attacked Brahmin orthodoxy with wit and irony. Jha was, in the assessment of Gajendra Thakur's Parallel History, the writer most unjustly denied the Sahitya Akademi award by the conservative establishment. The comparison with Mandal is illuminating: where Jha used the weapons of satire and irony (internal critique from within the dominant caste), Mandal deploys the weapons of empathetic realism (external critique from the marginalised community). Both are social critics, but their social locations produce structurally different literatures.

### 7.2 Mandal and Vidyapati (c. 1352–1448): Continuity and Rupture

Vidyapati, the great poet of medieval Mithila, wrote his celebrated padāvalī (lyric poetry) primarily in the register of Śṛṅgāra (erotic-devotional) rasa, in a highly Sanskritised Maithili patronised by the Karnāṭa-dynasty kings. Mandal's work represents both a continuity (deep rootedness in Maithili language and culture) and a radical rupture (displacement of the Brahminic and courtly aesthetic by a peasant-centred literary politics). The genealogical claims made by conservative Maithili literary institutions upon Vidyapati are precisely what Mandal's literary practice challenges: Vidyapati belongs to all Maithili speakers, not to any one caste.

### 7.3 Mandal and Rajkamal Chaudhary (1929–1967): The Avant-Garde and the Social Realist

Rajkamal Chaudhary is Maithili's great literary modernist, celebrated for experimental prose and verse that engaged with surrealism, stream of consciousness, and existentialist themes in both Maithili and Hindi. Where Chaudhary reached for universal modernist technique, Mandal remains committed to a social realism rooted in the specific experience of Mithila's non-

elite communities. These are not competing failures but complementary achievements: Maithili literature's range is measured by the distance between Rajkamal's Andolana and Mandal's Pangu.

### 7.4 Mandal and Gajendra Thakur: The Two Pillars of 'Parallel Literature'

Gajendra Thakur (b. 1971), editor of Videha and author of experimental polygenre works (Sahasrabadhani, Sankarshan, etc.), is the other major figure of what Videha calls 'parallel Maithili literature.' Where Thakur's work is characterised by formal experimentalism, Maithili linguistic archaeology, and digital activism, Mandal's strength lies in narrative clarity, social depth, and the authentic grain of the Maithili peasant's voice. Together, they represent complementary vectors of the democratisation of Maithili letters: Thakur providing the theoretical and institutional architecture, Mandal providing the literary substance.

### 7.5 Mandal and Usha Kiran Khan: Gender and Caste in Contemporary Maithili Fiction

Usha Kiran Khan's novel Bhamati (2010, Sahitya Akademi Award) deals with the life of Vacaspati Miśra's wife—an upper-caste woman who enables her husband's philosophical work in self-sacrifice. Khan's feminist Maithili fiction operates from within the Brahmin woman's experience of patriarchy; Mandal's fiction addresses the intersection of caste-subordination and gender from the OBC community's perspective. Both are necessary; their coexistence marks the maturity of contemporary Maithili fiction.

### 7.6 Mandal and Nagarjuna ('Yatri', 1911–1998): The Socialist-Realist Tradition

Nagarjuna (Vaidyanath Mishra, pen name 'Yatri'), despite being associated primarily with Hindi writing, won the Sahitya Akademi's Maithili prize, making his case controversial in the Videha parallel history framework. His Maithili verse—like Mandal's prose—was committed to the lives of the poor and marginalised. Both deploy Mithila's landscape and peasant culture as the ground of literary meaning. The difference lies in ideological framing: Nagarjuna worked from a Marxist-Communist framework, while Mandal's social critique is rooted in the lived experience of OBC community rather than imported ideology—closer, perhaps, to the social realism Premchand practised in Hindi.

## VIII. RECEPTION AND AWARDS

Jagdish Prasad Mandal received the Sahitya Akademi Award for 2021 for his novel Pangu (2018) at Sahityotsav, the Festival of Letters, in New Delhi in March 2022. This award, conferred by India's National Academy of Letters, is the most prestigious recognition available to Indian-language writers and marked the first time the Maithili Sahitya Akademi award had gone to a writer from a non-upper-caste community.

Senior Maithili litterateur Manikant Jha observed that 'Jagdish Mandal's works have always given rainbow colour to the sky of Maithili literature.' Former President of Maithili Academy, Pandit Kamla Kant Jha noted his 'continuous contribution to the development of Mithila and Maithili with his creations.' These testimonies, while conventional in their register, indicate Mandal's acceptance even within the literary establishment that had long excluded writers of his social background.

The Videha parallel history framework places Mandal's award in a broader political-literary context: the 2021 award broke a systematic pattern of caste-based exclusion documented by Gajendra Thakur. As Thakur notes in the Parallel History, the Sahitya Akademi's Maithili award had been distributed overwhelmingly (42 out of 51 awards prior to 2021) to Maithil Brahmin writers —a disproportion reflecting not literary merit but the institutional capture of the Akademi's advisory structure by conservative organisations.

Mandal's critical reputation within the 'parallel literature' movement is secure. He has been consistently published in Videha, featured in Outlook India's discussions of contemporary Maithili literature, and cited in academic studies of the 21st-century Maithili novel (A Critical Analysis of Maithili Novel: Twenty-First Century, IJIRT, December 2025). His Pangu is described in this academic survey as one of only three Maithili novels of the 21st century to win a Sahitya Akademi award (alongside Usha Kiran Khan's Bhamati and Asha Mishra's Uchat).

## IX. CONCLUSIONS: LITERARY SIGNIFICANCE AND LEGACY

Jagdish Prasad Mandal's place in Maithili literature is established on multiple grounds. As a social realist in the Lukácsian sense, he has created a body of fiction that offers the 'totality' of Maithili rural life from a perspective hitherto absent from the literary canon. As a practitioner of what postcolonial theory calls 'writing back' to the dominant culture, he has expanded the repertoire of Maithili literary subjects and styles. As a reader of Navya-Nyāya's epistemological spirit—the drive to make knowledge precise, verifiable, and

grounded in experience—he has contributed a new standard of narrative truth-telling to Maithili fiction.

Within the Indian aesthetic tradition, Mandal's primary achievement is the sustained evocation of karuṇa rasa—compassion—without sentimentality: a rasa that, in Abhinavagupta's understanding, achieves its full power precisely when it is grounded in the specificities of a recognisable social world. The dhvani of his best work—the resonant suggestion of systemic injustice beneath the surface of individual story—places him in the lineage of those Indian writers who understood that the most powerful literary statement is the one that is not fully stated.

Comparatively, Mandal stands as the Maithili answer to the challenge that writers like Munshi Premchand (Hindi), Fakir Mohan Senapati (Odia), and Rabindranath Tagore in his later stories posed: how to make vernacular literature the vehicle for the full humanity of communities that dominant culture had made invisible. He has succeeded in this project. Maithili literature after Mandal cannot return to its pre-Mandal narrowness.

His legacy is threefold: the democratisation of Maithili literary subjectivity (whose story is worth telling); the enrichment of Maithili narrative technique (how that story may be told with aesthetic power); and the institutional rupture represented by his Sahitya Akademi award (what the literary establishment is compelled to recognise). These three achievements together constitute a literary revolution conducted with the quiet persistence of a farmer who plants seeds not for today's harvest but for tomorrow's tree.

*Do not judge each day by the harvest you reap but by the seeds that you plant.* — — Robert Louis Stevenson, epigraph to Gajendra Thakur's critical study of Maithili parallel literature

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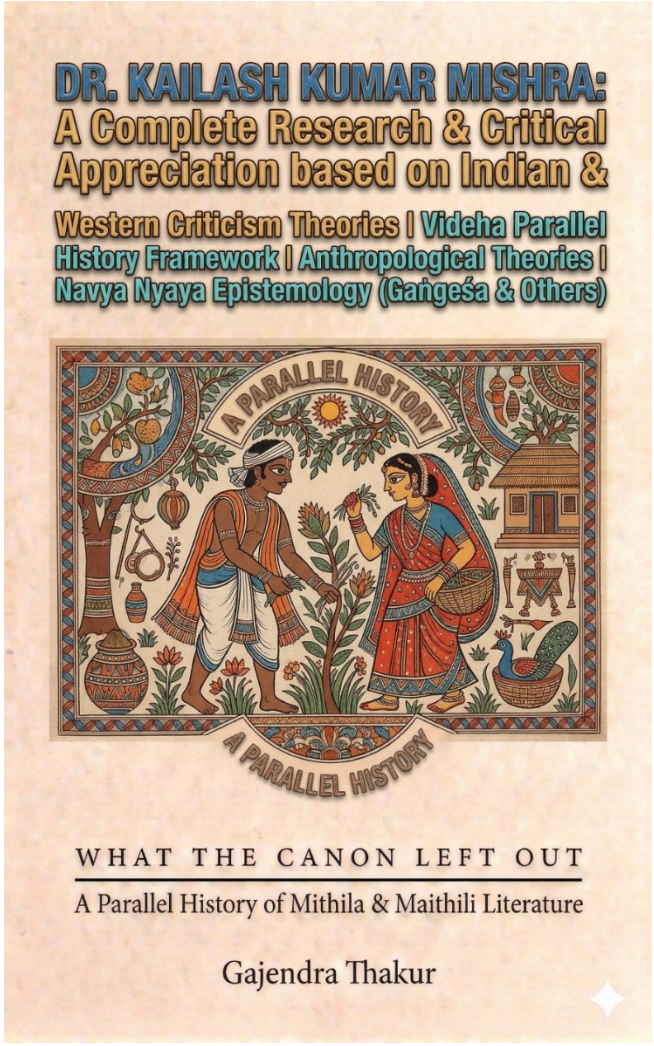
**LESSON 032 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**




# DR. KAILASH KUMAR MISHRA

*A Complete Research & Critical Appreciation*

Indian & Western Criticism Theories | Videha Parallel History Framework

Anthropological Theories | Navya Nyaya Epistemology (Gaṅgeśa & Others)

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## 1. Introduction: Who Is Dr. Kailash Kumar Mishra?

Dr. Kailash Kumar Mishra is one of the most versatile, prolific, and socially committed Maithili authors of the contemporary period. Born in village Ared (Areda), district Madhubani, Bihar—the heartland of Mithila civilisation—he has made Delhi his base of work while remaining tethered, in his imagination, to the cultural and ecological world of Mithila. His full address, as printed on his books, is B-2/333, Tarara Nagar, Old Palam Road, Dwarka Sector 15, New Delhi—110078 (mobile: 8076208498; email: kailashkmishra@gmail.com).

In terms of professional background, he worked as a researcher at the Indira Gandhi National Centre for the Arts (IGNCA), New Delhi—India's premier national institution for cultural research—where he was associated with the Lokasampada (Janpada Sampada) division under the renowned anthropologist Professor Baidyanath Saraswati. This institutional affiliation fundamentally shaped his scholarly and literary character: he is at once an anthropological fieldworker, a comparative cultural analyst, a travelogue writer, a novelist, and a grassroots Maithili activist.

His works span multiple genres: novels (upanyas), travelogue essays (yayavari/nibandhanibandhsamalochana), Facebook-based 'meta-history' of Mithila culture (Bookmeniya), and contributed chapters in major anthologies such as Videha Sadeha 29. His 2025 publications—Mansarbi (novel), Bookmeniya (meta-history), and the earlier Yayavari volume—are the primary texts examined in this critical appreciation.

He is closely associated with the Videha literary movement, the most significant digital and print platform for Maithili literary and cultural discourse, edited by Gajendra Thakur. Within this movement's framework—what Thakur calls the 'Videha Parallel History Framework'—Mishra represents the strain of writers who insist on recording marginalised, non-elite, and vernacular voices of Mithila, counterbalancing dominant high-caste Brahminical narratives.

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## 2. Biographical Context and Intellectual Formation

Mishra's intellectual formation is unusual in combining two streams that rarely meet in Indian scholarship: rigorous classical and institutional learning (IGNCA, fieldwork in ethnoaesthetics) and immersion in living oral-folk-

artisanal culture of Mithila. He received his higher education and doctoral training in the arts and humanities, and his academic publications include work on Mithila painting (Madhubani painting), Maithili folk songs, folk ritual, and comparative folk traditions across Northeast India.

His IGNCA research on Mithila paintings—published as 'Mithila Paintings: Past, Present and Future' (IGNCA, 2000)—is a landmark academic essay, widely cited in ethnographic and art-historical literature. This essay demonstrates his command of both sociological fieldwork methodology and classical Indian aesthetics. As he writes in this work:

> *Mithila is that sacred land where the founders of Buddhism and Jainism; the scholars of all six orthodox branches of Sanskrit learning such as Yajnavalkya, Bridha Vachaspati, Ayachi Mishra, Shankar Mishra, Gautam, Kapil, Sachal Mishra, Kumaril Bhatt and Mandan Mishra were born... Here in every house Saraswati dances with pride on the tip of the tongue of the learned. (Mishra, Kailash Kumar 2000)*

This layering of mythic-devotional, historical, and sociological registers in a single sentence is characteristic of Mishra's intellectual voice: he is always moving between ancient scriptures, contemporary social field, and personal lived experience.

His fieldwork took him to Northeast India—Arunachal Pradesh, North Cachar Hills, Assam—conducting workshops with tribal women's organisations on cultural identity, preserving indigenous traditions, and gender empowerment. These experiences are recorded with ethnographic precision in Yayavari. He worked alongside the Dimasa Mahila Utthan Samiti, the Zeliangrong Naga communities, the Jemi Naga women, and others, helping register women's cultural organisations under the Punjab Registration Act.

A significant biographical fact is the role of his grandmother (nani)—Shrimati Balmukhi Devi—who is the dedicatee of Mansarbi and from whom, he writes, he 'received the longing to understand stories and to make narrative from telling.' This maternal oral inheritance is central to understanding his literary genealogy.

# 3. Overview of Major Works

## 3.1 Mansarbi (Novel, 2025)

Published by Maitreyee Prakashan, Delhi (First Edition 2025, Price Rs. 200, ISBN 978-81-986846-4-6), Mansarbi is Mishra's debut novel in Maithili. The narrative centres on Bulki, a dalit/lower-caste woman in a Mithila village, and Raghab, a poor Brahmin youth, whose love unfolds against a landscape of caste oppression, gender violence, class exploitation, and rural poverty. The antagonist Mahananda—from the dominant 'rawar gachhi' (upper-caste enclave) of the village—embodies the feudal-caste violence that structures rural Mithila society.

The novel's preface (Monak Bayat) reveals the compositional history: it was originally serialised on social media, encouraged by noted Maithili author Dr. Usha Kiran Khan, then reconstructed after data loss during COVID-19. The narrative is described by the author as 'satyajaka' (like truth, but not truth)—a fictional reality that captures the essence of documented social conditions. The novel is dedicated to his grandmother, Shrimati Balmukhi Devi.

## 3.2 Yayavari (Travelogue-Essays, in Videha Maithili Prabandhanibandhsamalochana)

Yayavari collects travel essays by Mishra published in Videha's prose-essay series. The essays cover his fieldwork travels across North Cachar Hills (Assam), Arunachal Pradesh, Brindavan, and other cultural sites. They blend anthropological fieldwork reportage, personal memoir, cultural-historical exegesis, and social commentary. Notable pieces include essays on Mithila painting (Madhubani painting: past, present and future), Northeast tribal women's cultural preservation, the sacred geography of Brindavan, and comparative studies of folk traditions.

## 3.3 Bookmeniya (2025, Navarambh Prakashan, Rs. 250)

Bookmeniya is a unique genre experiment: a collection of Facebook posts by Mishra about the culture, history, mythology, and social life of Mithila and Maithili. The title itself is a portmanteau, combining 'Book' (Facebook) and 'meniya'—a Maithili suffix indicating a space or repository. The book thus constitutes a 'Facebook Meta-History' of Mithila: micro-essays, meditations, social observations, and cultural fragments distributed on social media and now

collected in print. It includes posts on such themes as: 'Spirit of Mithila and Maithili', 'Intangible [Heritage]', and cultural identity.

### 3.4 Videha Sadeha 29 (Co-authored with Ravibhushan Pathak)

Videha Sadeha is a thematic anthology series published by Videha collecting 'the finest Maithili prose and poetry' from the journal's 350 issues. Volume 29 features both Ravibhushan Pathak and Dr. Kailash Kumar Mishra. Mishra's contributions in this volume include: short stories (laghu katha), literary criticism, folk-culture essays on Maithili folk songs, wedding songs, ecological traditions, Saurath's Somnath parallels, book reviews, and literary-anthropological pieces on Madhubani painting and folk ritual.

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## 4. Critical Appreciation through Indian Literary Theory

### 4.1 Rasa Theory (Bharata Muni's Natyashastra)

The foundational Indian critical framework for evaluating literature is the theory of Rasa (aesthetic flavour/emotion) systematised by Bharata Muni in the Natyashastra (c. 200 BCE–200 CE), and elaborated by Abhinavagupta in the Abhinavabharati (10th–11th century CE). Rasa theory holds that literature communicates a generalised aesthetic emotion (Rasa) through the depiction of specific emotional states (Bhava) via language and narrative, and that the successful evocation of Rasa in the reader/spectator is the ultimate criterion of literary excellence.

Applying rasa theory to Mansarbi, the dominant rasa is clearly Karuna (pathos/compassion)—the aesthetic emotion of sorrow, evoked through the suffering of Bulki, Nirasa, and the marginalised characters of the village. However, the novel is polyphonic in its rasa economy. Shringara Rasa (the aesthetic of love) animates the scenes of Bulki's silent, embodied love for Raghab—her nursing his wounded foot (a scene of remarkable tenderness in the text), their stormy union in the monsoon night—even as this shringara is shadowed by social impossibility. The Vira Rasa (heroism) appears in Bulki's inner resistance and self-assertion. Bibhatsa Rasa (the disgusting, the revolting) colours the scenes of Rajkant's and Mahananda's violence and sexual predation.

In the Videha-Sadeha essays, the dominant rasa moves towards Shanta (peaceful contemplation) in the Brindavan meditation, and Adbhuta (wonder) in the descriptions of Naga tribal women's cultural resilience and the sublime ecology of Mithila's bamboo forests.

Abhinavagupta's contribution to Rasa theory is particularly relevant to Mishra's work: Abhinavagupta argued that Rasa is not merely the expression of personal emotion but a Sadharanikarana (universalisation) whereby the individual experience is transcended and becomes a shared, generalised aesthetic experience in the reader. Mishra's writing—whether in the novel or the travelogue—consistently achieves this: the story of Bulki is not merely a Bihar village story but becomes universally intelligible as the story of patriarchy, caste oppression, and the transcendence of human love.

## 4.2 Dhvani Theory (Anandavardhana)

Anandavardhana's Dhvanyaloka (9th century CE) posits that the 'soul of poetry' (kavyatman) is Dhvani—resonance or suggestive power—the capacity of literary language to suggest meanings beyond the literal denotation. This theory of 'suggested meaning' (vyanjana) as distinct from 'expressed meaning' (abhidha) and 'secondary meaning' (lakshana) is crucial to understanding Mishra's narrative technique.

Mansarbi's title itself operates as Dhvani. 'Mansarbi' is not a common Maithili word—it evokes the Sanskrit 'Manasa' (the heart-lake, the mind, the sacred Himalayan lake) combined with the feminine suffix, suggesting a woman who is the lake of the heart, the inner world, the depth of feeling. This suggestive title encodes the novel's central concern: the inner life of a woman who cannot be captured by her surface social identity.

Similarly, the recurring motif of bamboo in the Yayavari essays operates through Dhvani: bamboo is simultaneously ecological resource (threatened by rats and climate change), cultural symbol (associated with pastoral life, craft, music), and existential metaphor (flexibility under pressure, communal growth, regeneration after flowering and death). The bamboo's flowering, which causes mass rat population explosions and then ecological devastation, serves as a dhvani-laden symbol of cycles of oppression and liberation in the political economy.

## 4.3 Alamkara School (Bhamaha, Dandin)

The Alamkara (figure-of-speech) school of Sanskrit poetics, represented by Bhamaha (7th century) and Dandin (7th century), held that poetic figures—similes, metaphors, alliterations, etc.—are the primary ornaments and perhaps the essence of literary language. While Mishra's prose does not foreground ornate alamkara in the classical Sanskrit mode, his Maithili narrative prose deploys a distinctive regional folk-aesthetic that parallels the alamkara tradition.

In Mansarbi, for instance, Bulki is described through a sustained body metaphor: her calves (pindali), moving in a 'dance of sculpture' (sangarmar jaka tarasal), are a simile that evokes the classical Mithila sculptural tradition. When she carries grass and paddy on her head, she moves 'like a Mukuni elephant in rut'—an extended simile that connects her bodily power with the majestic animal imagery of folk-oral poetry (Mukuni hathi chal barsati). This deployment of folk-metaphor as literary alamkara is characteristic of Mishra's narrative style.

## 4.4 Vakrokti (Kuntaka) and Auchitya (Kshemendra)

Kuntaka's Vakroktijivita (10th century) proposed that the essence of poetry is 'oblique expression' (Vakrokti)—the creative deviation from ordinary usage that produces aesthetic delight. This theory is especially applicable to Mishra's narrative voice, which consistently deploys irony, indirection, and social satire. The scene of Rajkant 'gifting' bamboo to Bulki's father in exchange for sexual access is narrated with a devastating ironic indirection: the exchange is presented in the language of generosity and gratitude even as the coercive violence is apparent to the reader—a classic instance of vakrokti or oblique expression encoding social critique.

Kshemendra's Auchityavicharcharcha (11th century) proposed 'propriety' (auchitya)—contextual appropriateness—as the supreme criterion of literary excellence. Every element must be appropriate to character, context, genre, and social reality. Mishra's narrative demonstrates strong auchitya: the Maithili dialect, folk idioms, village ecology, caste-social dynamics, and character psychology are rendered with meticulous contextual appropriateness. The roughness of Mahananda's speech, the gentle diffidence of Raghab, the direct and earthy voice of Bulki—all achieve perfect auchitya.

# 5. Critical Appreciation through Western Literary Theories

## 5.1 Postcolonial Theory (Frantz Fanon, Homi K. Bhabha, Edward Said)

Mishra's entire literary project can be read within the postcolonial framework—particularly through the lens of what Frantz Fanon in The Wretched of the Earth (1961) calls the 'pitfalls of national consciousness': the danger that postcolonial nationalism will simply reproduce colonial hierarchies under new management. Mishra's writing is acutely alert to this danger: he documents how upper-caste Mithila identity and cultural nationalism have often silenced dalit, women's, and adivasi voices even while celebrating 'Maithili culture.'

Homi K. Bhabha's concepts of 'hybridity', 'mimicry', and 'third space' are productive for reading Mishra's Yayavari essays on Northeast India. The tribal women he encounters—Dimasa, Jemi Naga, Zeliangrong—occupy a third space between their indigenous traditions and the impositions of Christian missionary culture, Hindu nationalism, and urban modernity. Mishra's sympathetic but analytical observation of these communities—noting how Jemi Naga women maintain traditional marriage-marker hairstyles while negotiating RSS training, Christian ceremonies, and Indian legal personhood—maps precisely onto Bhabha's 'third space' of cultural negotiation.

Edward Said's Orientalism (1978) provides tools to critique the dominant discourse about Mithila that Mishra implicitly contests: a discourse in which Mithila is exoticised as the land of Madhubani paintings, Sita's birthplace, and Sanskrit scholarship—a discourse that erases the agrarian conflicts, caste violence, and flood-driven poverty that Mishra documents in both his ethnographic work and his fiction.

## 5.2 Subaltern Studies (Gayatri Spivak, Ranajit Guha)

The Subaltern Studies project, initiated by Ranajit Guha and theorised by Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak, asked whether the subaltern—those excluded from the dominant historical record—could 'speak' and be heard within existing textual and institutional structures. Spivak's foundational essay 'Can the Subaltern Speak?' (1988) argued that the subaltern woman, doubly marginalised by colonialism and patriarchy, is structurally silenced.

Mansarbi can be read as a direct fictional response to Spivak's question. Bulki—a dalit woman in a village, doubly subaltern by caste and gender—does

speak, does act, and does resist in Mishra's novel. Her resistance is embodied, practical, and largely without institutional support: she refuses to be shamed, she navigates the economics of exploitation with strategic intelligence (accepting bamboo in exchange for protecting her bodily integrity, then later asserting limits), and she maintains an inner world of love and dignity that survives repeated violation. Mishra's narrative technique grants her interiority and agency even as it documents the structural constraints that limit her options.

The question of who is authorised to narrate subaltern experience—raised critically by Spivak—is addressed in Mishra's preface (Monak Bayat) when he discusses the narrative ethics of writing from within (as someone who knows the social world) versus writing from outside. He invokes the Sanskrit/classical Indian critical concept of the writer needing 'Shiv tatva'—the capacity to inhabit the opposite gender's perspective—as a condition of adequate narrative representation.

## 5.3 Feminist Theory and Gender Studies

Mishra's engagement with feminist concerns is evident across all his works. In Mansarbi, the structural violence against Bulki—the bamboo 'transaction,' Rajkant's assault, Mahananda's broader reign of terror—is rendered without sentimentalisation or moralistic commentary. The narrative documents these events with ethnographic clarity, letting the social logic of exploitation speak for itself. This is consonant with materialist feminist criticism (Christine Delphy, Zillah Eisenstein) that analyses gender violence as a structural feature of class-caste-property relations rather than individual moral failure.

The figure of Rani Gaidinliu in the Yayavari essay on North Cachar Hills provides an extended study of a historical feminist subject: a Naga woman who led anti-colonial resistance from age thirteen, was captured by the British and imprisoned for fifteen years, was compared by Nehru to Joan of Arc and Rani Lakshmibai, and after independence continued to fight Christian missionary destruction of indigenous Naga culture. Mishra's portrayal of Gaidinliu—attentive to her multi-dimensional significance (freedom fighter, cultural protector, spiritual authority, female leader)—embodies an intersectional feminist analysis avant la lettre.

The Mithila painting essay (in Yayavari and IGNCA) offers a feminist cultural-political analysis: it documents how Mithila painting was originally a domestic, wall-based, women-only practice that was commodified in the 1960s by outside intervention (initiated to create employment after floods), and how this commodification both empowered women economically and altered the

cultural meaning and community context of the practice. This analysis anticipates debates in feminist art history about art, domestic labour, and commodification.

## 5.4 Formalism, New Criticism, and Narratology

From a New Critical standpoint (I.A. Richards, Cleanth Brooks, F.R. Leavis), Mishra's prose in Mansarbi demonstrates organic unity: the natural imagery (monsoon rains, bamboo groves, mango trees, buffaloes in mud), the folk-oral idioms, and the social narrative are woven into a textural whole in which no element is superfluous. The scene of Bulki and Raghab's union in the monsoon night—their wet clothes dissolving boundaries, their 'one from two' (ekakara)—is both erotically suggestive and cosmologically resonant (union with natural forces), achieving the 'tension' and 'irony' prized by New Criticism.

Applying Gérard Genette's narratological framework (Narrative Discourse, 1972), Mansarbi deploys a predominantly heterodiegetic narrator (third-person) with extensive access to characters' interiority through free indirect discourse (FID). The time structure moves between prolepsis (foreshadowing Bulki's later fate) and analepsis (filling in social-historical background). The narrative rhythm alternates between summary (covering long durations of social routine) and scene (dramatised action)—a technique that allows Mishra to embed individual drama within the slow time of agrarian social reproduction.

## 5.5 Cultural Materialism and Anthropological Literary Theory

Raymond Williams's cultural materialism—the idea that culture is a material practice embedded in specific social and economic formations—is perhaps the single most useful theoretical frame for Mishra's work, given his formation as a cultural anthropologist. In 'Marxism and Literature' (1977), Williams developed the concepts of 'residual', 'dominant', and 'emergent' cultural forms. Mishra's writings consistently map exactly this tripartite structure in Mithila culture: the residual (ancient Sanskrit learning, ritual, Madhubani painting), the dominant (contemporary caste hierarchy, capitalist commodification of folk art), and the emergent (dalit assertion, women's rights movements, digital cultural archiving through Videha).

James Clifford and George Marcus's Writing Culture (1986) addressed the question of ethnographic authority: whose voice speaks for a culture, and how is the 'I' of the ethnographer constructed in fieldwork writing. Mishra's Yayavari essays are deeply reflexive in this regard: he repeatedly positions himself not as expert-authority but as learner and guest, acknowledging that the tribal women

he encounters have knowledge and cultural authority he lacks. When the Karbi tribal woman challenges him for not wearing traditional Maithili clothing during his cultural preservation workshop, his response is an act of genuine reflexivity—acknowledging his own cultural alienation and making a commitment to re-embody Maithili tradition.

## 6. The Videha Parallel History Framework

The Videha Maithili eJournal (www.videha.co.in), edited by Gajendra Thakur since January 2008 (with antecedents in the Bhalsarik Gachh blog from 2000), has developed what its editorial tradition calls a 'Parallel History' (Samanantar Itihas) approach to Maithili literature and culture.

The core premise of the Videha Parallel History Framework is that official/canonical Maithili literary history—as narrated by dominant-caste critics and institutional gatekeepers (Sahitya Akademi, universities)—has systematically marginalised non-Brahmin, dalit, women, and non-elite writers while privileging a narrow upper-caste literary tradition. The Videha movement constitutes an alternative parallel history that:

- Archives and promotes works by writers from marginalised communities (Subhash Chandra Yadav, Rajdeo Mandal, Jagadish Prasad Mandal, and others)
- Critiques 'pseudo-literary criticism' (syndicated, caste-biased critical evaluation)
- Documents 'parallel' narratives of Maithili culture: the folk, the subaltern, the regional-marginal
- Maintains Videha Archive—a freely accessible digital repository of Maithili literature from ancient to contemporary
- Publishes in Tirhuta (Mithilakshar), Devanagari, and Braille scripts simultaneously

Mishra's work fits perfectly within this framework. Mansarbi narrates the lives of dalit-lower-caste characters who are entirely absent from dominant Maithili literary culture. Bookmeniya uses Facebook—the most democratic, mass-participatory digital medium—as a literary-historical medium. Yayavari documents cultural communities (Northeast tribal women, folk painters, ritual practitioners) outside the canonical Mithila cultural nationalist discourse. His

inclusion in Videha Sadeha 29 is not accidental but reflects his ideological alignment with the Parallel History project.

The concept of 'Parallel History' in the Videha framework also addresses a specific literary-critical distortion: the tendency to evaluate Maithili literature through standards derived from Hindi or Sanskrit literary norms rather than internal Maithili aesthetic criteria. Mishra's use of Maithili folk idiom, oral narrative structures, and village-ecological imagery is aesthetically validated within this framework on its own terms—not measured against any external standard.

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## 7. Anthropological Theories Applied to Mishra's Work

### 7.1 Clifford Geertz's Thick Description

Clifford Geertz's concept of 'thick description' (The Interpretation of Cultures, 1973) holds that ethnographic understanding requires interpreting cultural practices in their full context of meaning—not merely recording surface behaviour but decoding the layered symbolic significance of actions. Geertz's own famous example—the difference between a 'wink' and a 'twitch'—illustrates the interpretive work required.

Mishra's writing is, in effect, literary thick description. The Brindavan meditation in Yayavari is not merely a pilgrimage account but a thick description of the entire meaning-world of Vaishnava devotion: the 56-dish (Chhappan Bhog) offering to Banke Bihari, the history of Srivatsa Goswami's scholarship, the cosmological geography of Braj, the poet-saint traditions from Surdas to Vidyapati to Raskhan—all densely interwoven with Mishra's own biographical memory (his grandmother's teachings) and his first pilgrimage with his father. This is thick description achieving literary form.

### 7.2 Lévi-Strauss and Structural Anthropology

Claude Lévi-Strauss argued that myths and cultural practices have deep structural logic—they think through contradictions in social life by constructing narratives that 'mediate' between binary opposites (nature/culture, raw/cooked, male/female). His structural method in Mythologiques and

elsewhere provides a way to read the deep structure of Mithila cultural narratives.

The Yayavari essay on the parallel between Saurath's Somnath (Mithila) and Saurashtra's Somnath (Gujarat) is a remarkable instance of structural comparative analysis: Mishra traces the parallel mythological narratives, ritual practices, and folk traditions associated with two geographically distant Somnath temples, using the structural parallel to argue for deep cultural connections between the two regions. This is Lévi-Straussian comparative mythology applied to folk-historical evidence.

In Mansarbi, the structural opposition of 'rawar gachhi' (dominant-caste enclave) versus the Dalit/OBC households encodes a classic Lévi-Straussian structural opposition: culture vs. nature, purity vs. pollution, authority vs. labour. The novel's narrative resolution—Bulki's assertion of dignity against structural odds—can be read as a mythic narrative that 'mediates' these oppositions without resolving them, mirroring the actual social condition.

## 7.3 Victor Turner's Liminality and Communitas

Victor Turner's anthropological theory of liminality (from Arnold van Gennep's rites of passage, elaborated in The Ritual Process, 1969) describes the threshold state between social identities—the 'betwixt and between' condition of the initiate, the pilgrim, the traveler. Turner also developed the concept of 'communitas'—the spontaneous, egalitarian fellowship that emerges in liminal situations, transcending ordinary social structure.

Mishra's Yayavari essays are fundamentally accounts of liminal experience: the anthropologist-writer as perpetual traveler, moving between cultures, never fully insider or outsider. His account of the women's cultural gathering in North Cachar Hills—where, for a few days, tribal women of all Naga sub-groups gather in communitas, sharing traditional dress, songs, and cultural knowledge, temporarily suspended from ordinary social structure—is a description of Turner's communitas in its purest form.

The Brindavan pilgrimage essay is explicitly structured as a rite of passage: the journey from Delhi (the secular), through the sacred geography of Braj, to the moment of darshan (vision) at Banke Bihari and Radha Rani's temple—a classic Turnerian pilgrimage structure, ending not in the resolution of liminality but in its deepening, as the pilgrim carries Braj-consciousness back into the secular world.

### 7.4 Intangible Cultural Heritage: UNESCO Framework and Mishra

The UNESCO Convention for the Safeguarding of Intangible Cultural Heritage (2003) defines ICH as 'practices, representations, expressions, knowledge, and skills' transmitted across generations. Mishra's work—both his academic IGNCA research and his literary production—is thoroughly engaged with this framework, though always with a critical edge about who 'safeguards' whom.

His Mithila painting research explicitly addresses the commodification of folk art as ICH: when Madhubani painting was 'discovered' in the 1960s drought by urban art interventionists and transferred from walls to paper for sale, it gained international market value and 'preservation' but lost its original ritual context, community function, and women-only sacred practice character. This is the paradox of heritage: documentation and safeguarding can simultaneously transform and diminish the living practice.

In the Northeast India fieldwork essays, Mishra is deeply engaged with ICH preservation: conducting cultural workshops with tribal women, helping them document and assert their traditional practices against missionary and modernising pressures, and working with the Srimanta Sankardev Kalagama in Guwahati. His concern is always that ICH 'preservation' should serve community self-determination, not external (state or academic) agendas.

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## 8. Navya Nyaya Epistemology: Gaṅgeśa and the Logic of Literature

Navya Nyaya (New Logic) is a school of Indian epistemology and logic that emerged in Mithila—the same cultural region as Mishra—with Gaṅgeśa Upadhyaya's Tattvacintamani (c. 13th century CE), and was elaborated by a long line of Maithili logicians including Jayadeva Mishra (Alokam), Vardhamana Upadhyaya, Raghunatha Siromani, and later Jagadisha Tarkalankara and Gadadhara. This is Mishra's own philosophical heritage, and examining his work through the Navya Nyaya framework is not merely an academic exercise but an act of cultural hermeneutics—reading the texts through the epistemological tools his own cultural tradition produced.

## 8.1 Pramana (Valid Cognition) in Mishra's Narratives

Navya Nyaya identifies four primary Pramanas (sources of valid cognition): Pratyaksha (direct perception), Anumana (inference), Upamana (comparison/analogy), and Shabda (testimony/verbal authority). In applying these to literary epistemology—the question of how literature generates valid knowledge about the world—we find Mishra's work particularly rich.

Pratyaksha-based knowledge in Mishra is the detailed, sensory-phenomenological narration of lived experience: the texture of mud on bare feet after monsoon rain, the smell of a bamboo grove, the specific weight and balance of a grass-load on a woman's head, the distinctive movement of callused hands. Mishra's literary Pratyaksha is emphatically embodied—rooted in the sensory knowledge of rural labour and village ecology.

Anumana (inferential reasoning) operates throughout Mishra's social analysis. In Mansarbi, the repeated inferential move from specific village events (Nirasa's beating, Bulki's assault, Mahananda's impunity) to the general proposition about caste-feudal social structure is a literary Anumana: from particular instances to structural inference. In the painting essay, the inference from women's art practices to the nature of their social world and epistemological framework is explicit methodological Anumana.

## 8.2 Vyapti (Invariable Concomitance) as Narrative Logic

The central technical achievement of Navya Nyaya is its precise analysis of Vyapti—the invariable concomitance (universal rule) that underwrites inferential reasoning. 'Where there is smoke, there is fire' holds because of the Vyapti: the invariable concomitance of smoke and fire. Navya Naiyayikas developed an extraordinarily precise technical vocabulary for distinguishing genuine Vyapti from apparent concomitance, handling exceptions, and dealing with counter-examples.

Mishra's literary project can be understood as constructing and interrogating Vyaptis about social life. The apparent Vyapti of caste society—'where there is a Brahmin, there is authority and purity; where there is a Dalit, there is labour and pollution'—is the dominant social epistemology that Mansarbi challenges. Through the particular stories of Bulki, Raghab, and their community, the novel shows that this Vyapti is false: the actual concomitance is not between caste and intrinsic worth but between caste and inherited privilege sustained by violence.

This is precisely the Navya Nyaya operation of Badhakapramana—the production of defeating evidence that nullifies a false Vyapti. Mishra's fiction

and essays produce Badhakapramanas against the dominant social Vyaptis of Mithila's caste hierarchy.

### 8.3 Shabda Pramana, Oral Tradition, and Literary Authority

In Navya Nyaya, Shabda Pramana (verbal testimony) is valid when it comes from an Apta—a reliable, authoritative, trustworthy speaker with direct knowledge. The question of who counts as Apta—whose testimony is epistemically authoritative—maps directly onto the politics of literary and cultural authority.

Mishra's narrative project involves a systematic expansion of who counts as Apta in Maithili cultural discourse. The grandmother telling folk stories, the Dimasa tribal woman describing her community's sanitation struggle, the Naga woman explaining traditional marriage markers, Bulki herself—these are all constituted as Aptas: their testimony is presented as reliable, grounded, and authoritative. This is a cultural-political act of epistemological democratisation.

The concept of Paroksha (indirect knowledge, knowledge based on inference and testimony as opposed to direct perception) is also relevant. Much of what Mishra narrates in Yayavari is knowledge acquired through Shabda Pramana—oral interviews, community conversations, local guides. His literary methodology validates this Paroksha knowledge as substantive and reliable, against academic conventions that privilege textual or archival documentation over oral testimony.

The Navya Nyaya concept of Anuvyavasaya—reflective metacognition, the awareness of one's own cognitive processes—appears in Mishra's reflexive prefaces and author-notes, where he explicitly reflects on the epistemological and ethical conditions of his narrative authority.

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## 9. Analysis of Individual Works

### 9.1 Mansarbi: A Novel of Caste, Gender, and Mithila's Rural Economy

Mansarbi (2025) is structured around two intersecting narrative strands: the story of Bulki and Raghab's love (Shringara), and the story of caste-feudal violence (Karuna/Bibhatsa) enacted by Rajkant and Mahananda against the village's weaker members. These strands are woven together through the

geography of the village—the bamboo groves, the paddy fields, the 'rawar gachhi,' the Dalit quarter—which functions as both setting and social map.

The novel's realism is of a specific kind: not naturalism's deterministic pessimism, but what in Indian critical terms would be called Lokavritta (social reality)—the honest depiction of social conditions as they are, without idealisation or melodrama. Bulki is not a heroine in any conventional sense: she is a woman with desires, strategic intelligence, practical skill, and vulnerability. Her final refusal to remarry or be 'solved' by social convention is a form of quietist resistance—choosing dignity and autonomy over the solutions offered by a patriarchal society.

The character of Raghab, the poor Brahmin youth, is complex: he loves Bulki genuinely but is structurally unable to protect or sustain her within the village's social order. His passivity before Mahananda's violence is not cowardice but the realistic assessment of structural powerlessness—the 'marta kya na karta' (the desperate do what they must) logic that Mishra renders without condemnation.

Mahananda—the novel's principal antagonist—is rendered not as a simple villain but as a systematic type: the feudal-caste violence specialist who maintains social order through terror. His beatings of Nirasa (a debtor too poor to repay), his humiliation of lower-caste individuals, his co-option of other castes into the system of domination—these are shown as social-structural functions, not individual aberrations.

## 9.2 Yayavari: Travelogue as Cultural Anthropology

The travelogue essays in Yayavari constitute perhaps the most generically hybrid of Mishra's works: they are simultaneously personal memoir, ethnographic fieldwork report, cultural history, and literary essay. This hybridity—bridging the personal and the scholarly, the intimate and the analytical—is what makes them exceptional.

The North Cachar Hills essay exemplifies the genre: it opens with Mishra arriving in Haflong (Assam), moves through his workshop activities with tribal women from multiple communities (Dimasa, Jemi Naga, Kuki, Biate, etc.), includes an extended portrait of Rani Gaidinliu, documents the conflict between indigenous tradition and Christian missionary cultural transformation, and ends with a meditation on collective cultural resilience. The author's emotional arc—from academic purpose to genuine personal transformation,

including his acceptance of the Karbi tribal woman's challenge about his own neglect of Maithili dress—gives the essay its human depth.

The Brindavan essay is more inward, more meditative: a personal pilgrimage structured around the author's childhood memories of his grandmother's teachings, his discovery of the Chhappan Bhog (56-dish offering) tradition through Srivatsa Goswami's research, and his father's knowledge of Braj geography. It reads as an essay in what Paul Ricoeur would call 'narrative identity'—the construction of the self through the stories and places that form one's cultural inheritance.

## 9.3 Bookmeniya: The Facebook Meta-History

Bookmeniya is formally unprecedented in Maithili literature: a book composed of Facebook posts. This genre choice has profound epistemological and cultural-political implications. Facebook is a medium of immediacy, informality, and democratic mass participation—the polar opposite of the formal scholarly monograph or the canonical literary text. By collecting these posts into a book, Mishra elevates the ephemeral and popular to the status of permanent cultural record.

The content of Bookmeniya—as suggested by the limited text extracted from the digital version—includes cultural reflections on 'Spirit of Mithila and Maithili,' accounts of intangible cultural heritage, and metahistorical observations about Mithila's cultural position in Indian civilisation. This is cultural history written from below, in real time, with the informal authority of lived experience rather than institutional sanction.

The concept of 'meta-history' in the title is significant: Mishra is not merely recording history but reflecting on the conditions and frameworks of historical narration. The Facebook medium—with its real-time feedback, comment-threads, and social network context—makes this meta-historical dimension visible in the text's very form.

## 9.4 Videha Sadeha 29: Prose, Poetry, and Critical Essays

Mishra's contributions to Videha Sadeha 29 demonstrate the full range of his literary forms: short stories, literary criticism, and folk-cultural essays. The short stories (laghu katha) including 'Panditain,' 'Buri Raj,' and others display his capacity for compressed, ironic social narrative in the tradition of Maithili satirical fiction. The folk-cultural essays—on Maithili folk songs, Madhubani painting, Saurath-Saurashtra comparative analysis, and the ritual sacrifice of

goats (chagar balidan)—show his ethnoaesthetic methodology at its most systematic.

The comparative piece on Saurath's Somnath and Saurashtra's Somnath is particularly striking: it uses parallel historical and mythological evidence to argue for deep civilisational connections between two regions superficially distant in geography and culture. This structural-comparative methodology—tracing invariant cultural patterns across geographic variations—is simultaneously Lévi-Straussian structural anthropology and Navya Nyaya analogical reasoning (Upamana pramana).

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## 10. Thematic Synthesis

Reading across all of Mishra's works examined here, several major themes emerge with consistency:

### *a. The Dignity of the Marginalised*

Whether in Mansarbi's Bulki, the Dimasa women of North Cachar Hills, the Jemi Naga female freedom fighters, or the Mithila painting artists from lower castes, Mishra's literature insists on the full human dignity and cultural agency of those marginalised by caste, gender, class, or ethnic origin. This thematic commitment is both ethical and aesthetic: the marginalised are portrayed not as victims awaiting rescue but as active subjects with complex inner lives and strategic capacities.

### *b. The Ecology of Mithila*

Bamboo groves, paddy fields, monsoon rains, mango trees, sacred rivers, flood plains—Mithila's ecology is not merely backdrop but living protagonist in Mishra's writing. The essay on bamboo flowering in Arunachal Pradesh (in Yayavari) explores the ecological-cultural knowledge of tribal communities who understand and live with the bamboo's fifty-year flowering cycle and its economic consequences. This ecological consciousness connects Mishra's work to contemporary environmental humanities discourse.

### *c. Cultural Memory and Continuity*

Across all genres, Mishra documents cultural memory: the memory encoded in Madhubani painting motifs, in Maithili folk songs (particularly those associated with life-cycle rituals: birth, mundan, marriage, death), in

pilgrimage traditions, in the oral narratives his grandmother transmitted. This documentation is not antiquarian nostalgia but active cultural politics—claiming the right of marginalised communities to their own cultural inheritance.

### *d. The Ethics of the Intellectual*

Mishra's reflexive author-positions across his texts constitute an ethics of the intellectual: the researcher/writer who does not merely observe but participates, who accepts the moral challenges of his subjects (the Karbi woman's challenge about Maithili dress), who acknowledges the limits of his authority, and who commits to using his literacy and institutional access in service of communities less institutionally empowered.

### *e. Language, Script, and Cultural Survival*

The Maithili language itself—spoken by approximately 40 million people, recognised in the Eighth Schedule of the Indian Constitution in 2003, written in both Tirhuta/Mithilakshar and Devanagari scripts—is a recurring preoccupation. Mishra's commitment to writing in Maithili rather than Hindi (despite living in Delhi and being academically fluent in English) is a cultural-political choice. The Videha movement's publication in Mithilakshar, Devanagari, and Braille simultaneously reflects this multilayered commitment to language preservation and democratisation.

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## 11. Conclusion and Critical Assessment

Dr. Kailash Kumar Mishra occupies a distinctive position in contemporary Maithili literature as a writer who combines the rigor of trained cultural anthropology with the creative energy of fiction and the democratic accessibility of social media engagement. His 2025 publications—Mansarbi, Bookmeniya, and the earlier Yayavari—demonstrate a sustained and maturing literary project that addresses the most pressing concerns of Mithila's social and cultural life.

His greatest strength is the capacity for what can be called 'sympathetic specificity': the ability to render the particular—a specific woman in a specific village in a specific season—with enough textural detail and emotional intelligence that it becomes universally recognisable as human experience. This is the literary achievement that Indian aesthetics calls Sadharanikarana

(universalisation through particularity) and that Western narratology identifies as the movement from fabula (raw story) to discourse (told story) to significance.

His limitations, if any, lie in the tension between the descriptive richness of his anthropological-essayistic mode and the demands of sustained novelistic narrative architecture. Mansarbi, while powerful in individual scenes and character moments, sometimes moves between episodes with the episodic rhythm of the ethnographic field note rather than the cumulative inevitability of the best social-realist fiction. This is perhaps inevitable in a first novel, and may also be a deliberate formal choice aligned with oral-episodic narrative traditions.

Through the multiple critical frameworks applied in this study—Indian rasa theory, dhvani, Navya Nyaya epistemology; postcolonial theory, subaltern studies, feminist theory, structural anthropology; and the Videha Parallel History Framework—a coherent picture emerges: Kailash Kumar Mishra is a writer of serious moral and aesthetic commitment, rooted in the deepest cultural traditions of Mithila, yet engaging fully with the contemporary social and intellectual world. His work represents precisely what the Videha Parallel History project calls for: literature that speaks from the margin with the authority of lived experience, that reclaims the full complexity of Maithili life, and that insists on the dignity and historical agency of those the dominant narrative has silenced.

In the classical Navya Nyaya formulation: his texts are Aptas—reliable witnesses with direct knowledge—and their Shabda Pramana constitutes valid knowledge about Mithila's social reality. In the Abhinavagupta formulation: his writing achieves Sadharanikarana—the universalisation of particular experience into shared aesthetic and moral awareness. In the Spivakian formulation: he ensures that the subaltern speaks—and is heard.

ADDENDUM

**Critical Appreciation**

*of*

## अरेड़: गामक लोक इतिहास

*(Arer: Gamak Lok Itihas)*

by Dr. Kailash Kumar Mishra

*Pen to Print Publishing LLP, New Delhi | ISBN: 978-93-92877-52-0*

**Analytical Frameworks Applied**

Anthropological Theory (Cultural, Social, Historical & Ethno-Historical Anthropology)

Folkloristics & Oral History (Propp, Ong, Lord–Parry Tradition)

Subaltern Studies & Postcolonial Theory (Guha, Chakrabarty, Spivak)

Videha Parallel History Framework (Gajendra Thakur / Videha e-Journal)

Indian Classical Aesthetics: Rasa, Dhvani, Loka-dharmi

Memory Studies & Micro-History (Nora, Ginzburg, Assmann)

## I. Preamble: The Book and Its Author

Dr. Kailash Kumar Mishra's *Arer: Gamak Lok Itihas* (Arer: The People's History of the Village) is a remarkable act of vernacular micro-historiography. Published by Pen to Print Publishing LLP, New Delhi, with an ISBN of 978-93-92877-52-0, the text is written primarily in Maithili — the language of the author's community — with Hindi and some English passages interspersed, reflecting the lived multilingual ecology of the Madhubani district of Mithila. The book's subtitle, *Gamak Lok Itihas* (the people's history of a village), declares its genre and its politics simultaneously: this is not official history but *lok* (people's/oral/folk) history, recovered through memory, community testimony, and the author's own ethnographic fieldwork.

The author is a trained social scientist who has worked with the UNESCO–UNDP project "Gramya Bharat" and participated in research on numerous Indian villages. Yet his deepest motivation for writing this book is personal: Arer is the village of his birth, and the book is dedicated to his mother Shrimati Shivdulari Devi and father Shri Ramanandan Mishra. This combination of academic method and autobiographical rootedness is the book's defining tension and its principal strength.

The book covers seventeen chapters that together constitute a social, cultural, ecological, economic, and spiritual biography of Arer village — a village in the Benipatti Block of Madhubani district, Bihar, situated along the Madhubani–Benipatti state road, comprising fourteen tolas (sub-settlements) spread across two panchayats (Arer Dakshin and Arer Uttari). Its geography, etymology, demographic composition, folk heroes, freedom fighters, religious institutions,

educational reformers, and familial stories are all documented here with the care of an ethnographer and the affection of a native son.

## Authorial Context

Dr. Mishra's background as an ethno-historian and fieldworker is visible throughout the text. He draws on family oral tradition (his father's and mother's recollections), community testimony gathered over years, Facebook exchanges with village elders, the written notes of local scholars, and his own childhood memories. He is candid about the limitations of his sources, noting where accounts are uncertain, where documentary corroboration is lacking, and inviting others to extend the project. This epistemic modesty is both methodologically admirable and, as we shall see, politically significant.

# II. Anthropological Frameworks: Reading Arer

## 1. Cultural Anthropology: The Village as a Total Social Fact

Marcel Mauss's concept of the *fait social total* (total social fact) — the idea that any significant cultural practice simultaneously expresses social, economic, religious, juridical, and aesthetic dimensions — is an apt analytical lens for the material Mishra assembles. Arer is not simply a settlement: it is a *sampoorna vyaktitva* (complete personality), to use the author's own phrase, constituted by the labour of its people, the ecology of its land (flood-free, fertile, three-crop), the network of its tanks (pokhari), its sacred sites (Brahmasthaan, Mahadevasthaan, Durgaasthaan), its wrestling arena (akhara), its market (haat), its schools and libraries, and the oral traditions that bind all these together.

Mishra's method is essentially what Bronisław Malinowski called *participant observation* combined with what Clifford Geertz theorised as *thick description* — the practice of reading cultural events not merely as surface behaviours but as texts in a larger symbolic system. The narrative of Bachha Jha First's wrestling bout with a Nepali champion at the Darbhanga court, for instance, is not just a sports story: it is a text about the honour economy of Maithili society, the relationship between the village and the princely state, the ethics of martial culture (akhara-dharma), and the politics of colonial encounter (the incident of the British officer at Saurath Sabha Gachhi, who smokes a cigarette in a sacred precincts and is felled by Bachha Jha with a single blow).

## 2. Social Anthropology: Caste, Commensality, and Community

The book provides a meticulous record of Arer's caste composition: Brahmin, Kshatriya, Dom, Kumhar, Mallah, Dhanukh, Yadav, Lahari, Musahar, Koeri, Kurmi, Kalwar, Кеват, Suri, Nuniyar, Bania, Halwai, Dhimar, Turha, Patwa, Dhobi, Kayastha, Lohar, Dusadh, Bhumihar, Amat, Mandal, Pasi, and others. This is a sociologically complete record of the jati-varna composition of a Mithila village across the full spectrum from Brahmin to Scheduled Caste — a record that is itself an act of counter-documentation against the upper-caste bias of official village surveys.

The text's most striking social-anthropological claim is its insistence on the village's *aapasi sauhaarda* (inter-community harmony). An Amat (low-caste) headman who has no male heir adopts his son-in-law into the household; Muslim Kumhars sing *nacharis*, *maheshvanis*, and *bhajans* in sweet voices; a

Muslim woman named Reshma is addressed as *mausi* (maternal aunt) by the author's family, by the mother's explicit instruction. These micro-narratives are what anthropologists call *evidence of lived pluralism* — the everyday intercommunal sociality that official communal historiography tends to suppress.

However, Mishra's text does not romanticise. The author acknowledges "some people and families who attempted to compromise the village's dignity and honour" in the same breath as celebrating its achievers. This is the sociological honesty that distinguishes ethnographic practice from hagiography.

## 3. Historical Anthropology and Ethno-History

Historical anthropology — the study of the past through the cultural practices, oral traditions, and material traces of communities rather than through state archives alone — is the book's dominant mode. Mishra is aware of the problem that most formal historians in Mithila have ignored *lok itihas* (oral/people's history). He poses the question directly: "When did established historians ever pause to attend to people's history?" (*Kabhi ne kaiyek sthaapit itihaaskaar lok itihas par bauk chhath?*). His answer is to fill this silence himself.

The concept of ethno-history — the reconstruction of historical events and processes through the oral traditions, folklore, and cultural memory of a community — is directly applicable here. The oral traditions Mishra records about Bachha Jha First (late 18th–early 19th century wrestler and anti-colonial figure), Bachha Jha Second (cultivator, educationist, and community builder, c. 1870–1955), the independence fighter Ramananda Sahu (1942 Quit India Movement), the village development champion Vishwambhar Jha (1930s–1970), and the saints Sudarshan Das–Sita Ram Das–Ram Chandra Das — these constitute what Jan Vansina, in his seminal work on oral tradition as historical source, calls *traditions-as-history*: testimonies that, when critically assessed for their transmission chain and internal consistency, yield genuine historical knowledge.

The multi-generational oral tradition about Bachha Jha First is particularly remarkable. The account of his confrontation with a British officer at Saurath Sabhagachhi — a sacred literary-matrimonial gathering of the Maithil Brahmin community — functions on multiple levels: as a historical datum about anticolonial resistance in rural Mithila; as a narrative of cultural boundary-maintenance (the sacred space must not be desecrated by tobacco smoke); and as a legend of extraordinary physical power whose motifs (the wrestler grows to three times his normal size when preparing for combat; a Punjabi champion

acknowledges him as guru without a bout; he bends iron chains in prison) follow the morphology of the folk-hero narrative documented by Alan Dundes and Vladimir Propp.

## 4. Oral Tradition and Folkloristics

Walter Ong's distinction between primary oral culture (cultures without literacy) and residual orality (cultures that have literacy but preserve strong oral transmission alongside it) is instructive here. Arer is a village with a long Sanskrit-literary tradition (fourteen naimiittika Vaidikas — Vedic specialists — at one time; a gurukulam founded by Pandit Rattlelal Jha Vaidik), yet its most vital historical knowledge is carried orally — in the "lok kantha" (community throat/memory). Mishra is careful to note that without documentation, "in a few centuries very few people will remember them."

The Bachha Jha narratives display the formal features of what Albert Lord and Milman Parry identified as the oral-formulaic tradition: repetitive epithets ("saat phit ke chhalah" — he was seven feet tall; "sharir paanch guna vistaar le lait chhalah" — his body expanded five times), thematic clusters (the hero refuses royal patronage to stay with his village; the hero defeats the outsider champion; the hero breaks iron chains effortlessly), and a narrative grammar in which supernatural power is always anchored in specific local sacred practice (invoking the *kuldevata* of Arer before each bout, prostrating before the Brahma-sthaan of the village).

The story of the Durga Puja presided over by Buddhinator Jha — with its narrative of the Lakshminia Bakhari (the granary that miraculously refills itself), the tilted Durga idol that rights itself when the entire village prays in unison, and the conspiracy to steal sacred offerings through tantric practice — belongs to the genre of what Alan Dundes called "religious belief legends" (Sagen): tales that function to reinforce community solidarity and sacred boundaries. Mishra presents these legends with appropriate anthropological care: neither debunking them rationalistically nor accepting them uncritically, but instead documenting the community's relationship to them as a social fact in its own right.

## 5. Memory Studies: Lieux de Mémoire and the Village

Pierre Nora's concept of *lieux de mémoire* (sites of memory) — specific physical or symbolic sites around which collective memory crystallises when living memory begins to fade — is particularly illuminating for Arer. The book documents several such sites: the Brahmasthaan (the founding sacred site of the

Dih-settlers, housing the deities of the village's origin); the Akhara Gachhi (Bachha Jha's wrestling grove, now converted to fields but still remembered); the Durgasthaan of Purwari Tol (established by Buddhinator Jha, site of a hundred years of continuous worship); the Khadi Bhandar and library established by Vishwambhar Jha; and the Bachha Jha Janta Uchcha Vidyalaya (the high school that bears his name).

Each of these sites is both a material location and a symbolic anchor for community memory. As Jan Assmann argues in his distinction between communicative memory (living oral memory, spanning three to four generations) and cultural memory (institutionalised, ritual-encoded, longer-term collective identity), Arer is in the process of the critical transition between these two forms: the living communicative memory of the village elders is being converted into cultural memory through Mishra's act of documentation. The book itself becomes a *lieu de mémoire*: a site at which the village's dispersed, aging, orally-held memory is crystallised into archivable text.

# III. The Videha Parallel History Framework

The Videha Parallel History Framework, articulated by Gajendra Thakur through the Videha e-Journal (ISSN 2229-547X, www.videha.co.in) and associated publications, argues that Maithili cultural and literary history has always contained two streams: the mainstream tradition associated with upper-caste (Brahmin, Kayastha) literary culture and official institutions, and the *parallel tradition* composed of subaltern voices, non-elite communities, and geographically peripheral experience. This framework extends naturally to the domain of historiography.

## 1. Arer as a Case of Parallel History

Arer village is precisely the kind of social formation that the Videha Parallel History Framework is designed to illuminate. It is not a seat of the Maithili literary establishment (not Darbhanga, Madhubani town, or a metropolitan centre), but a multi-caste agricultural village in the Madhubani periphery. Its history includes no famous poets or Sanskrit scholars of the mainstream literary canon (though it had its own Vaidik pandits and a gurukul). Its heroes are a wrestler-farmer who defied a British officer, an independence fighter from the Sahu (OBC) community whose name never appears in official Bihar freedom fighter records, a self-made cultivator-educationist of modest background who donated land and money for a high school, and a chain of devotional saints across the caste spectrum.

This is precisely the "parallel" history that official historiography and official literary-cultural institutions have excluded. As Thakur has documented, the Maithili Akademi of Patna, the Sahitya Akademi of Delhi, and associated institutions have consistently foregrounded the Brahmin-Kayastha mainstream at the expense of the plural social reality of Mithila. Mishra's book is a micro-historiographical corrective: it writes the history of Mithila from within a single multi-caste village, recovering the contributions of all *jati-varna* groups — including Mallahs (fishermen), Kumhars (potters), Musahars (a Scheduled Caste community), Dhanukhs, Yadavs, and Muslims.

## 2. The Question of Whose History is Written

Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's question "Can the Subaltern Speak?" — about the structural impossibility of hearing subaltern voices through the apparatus of dominant historiography — is answered affirmatively by Mishra's method, though with important qualifications. Ramananda Sahu, the Sahu (OBC)

community independence fighter of Arer, participated in the 1942 Quit India Movement, destroyed electricity poles, was captured by the British, had his moustache hairs pulled out one by one, and refused to name his associates even under torture. His name is absent from Bihar's official freedom fighter records, while others with weaker credentials have secured state recognition and pension. Mishra's chapter on Sahu is an act of subaltern historiography in Guha's sense: the recovery of a suppressed history from the community's oral memory.

The Videha framework's insistence on documenting non-mainstream Maithili history resonates directly with Mishra's project. Just as Gajendra Thakur has used the Videha archive to document parallel literary traditions, genealogical records (panji prabandh), and the contributions of non-Brahmin scholars, Mishra uses the lok itihas genre to document the contributions of farmers, wrestlers, merchants, freedom fighters, and saints from across the social spectrum of a single village.

## 3. The Mithila Connection: Arer in Mythological-Historical Space

Mishra's ethno-historical analysis of Arer's name is itself a contribution to parallel Mithila history. The name "Arer" derives from "andi" (castor-oil plant), which once grew abundantly in the village; the Sanskrit scholars converted this to "Areru"; the colonial banking administration anglicised it to "ANRER"; and common Maithili usage preserves "Arer." This multilinguistic sedimentation of the village's name is a microcosm of Mithila's broader linguistic history — the co-presence of Maithili vernacular, Sanskrit classical, and colonial administrative naming.

More significantly, the author argues (on the basis of text analysis and local oral tradition) that the village lay on an ancient trade and pilgrimage route connecting the Gaya–Rajgir–Nalanda–Sarnath Buddhist circuit with Nepal, and that it may have been on the route Mahakavi Kalidasa travelled between Uchaith (a famous Mithila site) and Ujjain. Whether or not these specific claims can be verified, the epistemological move is important: it situates a small agricultural village not as a marginal footnote to Mithila history but as a participant in the major religious-cultural circuits of the subcontinent. This is the Videha framework's "parallel history" approach applied at the micro-historical level: the village is not outside Mithila's grand narratives but constitutive of them.

# IV. Postcolonial and Subaltern Analysis

## 1. The Colonial Encounter: Bachha Jha and the British Officer

The central anticolonial moment in the book — Bachha Jha First's killing of a British officer who refuses to stop smoking at the sacred Saurath Sabhagachhi — is a compelling case for postcolonial analysis. Homi Bhabha's concept of the *colonial encounter* as a space of mimicry, ambivalence, and sudden violent rupture is directly applicable. The British officer represents colonial authority and racial contempt ("You who are you to stop me? I shall do as I please"). Bachha Jha's intervention is not a premeditated act of political resistance but an eruption of cultural self-assertion: the sacred space shall not be desecrated by colonial power, regardless of that power's military and legal authority.

The consequences are significant: Bachha Jha flees to Nepal, is eventually tried before a British magistrate (whose wife, recognising his extraordinary strength and character, advocates for his innocence), is acquitted, and returns to Arer. The narrative arc — criminal charge, imprisonment, extraordinary physical demonstration before the colonial judge's wife, acquittal, triumphant return — follows the structure of what Ranajit Guha, in *Elementary Aspects of Peasant Insurgency*, calls the "prose of counter-insurgency": the state apparatus attempts to discipline the subaltern body, but the subaltern's extraordinary qualities ultimately compel recognition even within the colonial framework.

## 2. Ramananda Sahu: The Unregistered Freedom Fighter

The chapter on Ramananda Sahu is the book's most direct intervention in the politics of historical memory. Sahu participated in the 1942 Quit India Movement at the age of forty, destroying electricity poles, shouting anticolonial slogans, withstanding police bullets, and enduring the plucking of his moustache hairs under British detention. Yet his name does not appear in Bihar's official freedom fighter records, while others with weaker credentials have secured state recognition.

This erasure is precisely what Gyan Pandey, in his work on communal violence and subaltern history, calls "the prose of the archive": the official record is not a neutral accumulation of facts but a politically constituted selection that systematically excludes certain classes of actors. Sahu is excluded because he was from the Sahu (Teli) OBC community, had no powerful patrons, and refused — with extraordinary self-respect — to register his freedom-fighting credentials for material benefit (pension, railway pass, health care). Mishra's

recovery of Sahu's story from the community's oral memory is an act of what Dipesh Chakrabarty calls "provincialising" the official historical record: forcing it to acknowledge the local, the unnamed, and the principled.

## 3. The Question of Development and Women

The book is noteworthy for its brief but pointed reflection on the condition of women in Mithila. In Chapter 3 ("Mithilak Gaam: Anek Samasyaa aur Itihas"), Mishra observes that Mithila — one of the most celebrated regions of India for its literary-cultural heritage (Vidyapati, Gangesa Upadhyaya, the Madhubani painting tradition) — has also been a society where "the condition of women and the cruelty to widows (vidhavaak sang atyaachaar)" is a persistent reality. He does not develop this observation at length, but its placement in the context of a chapter on the village's problems and development challenges is significant: the gendered dimension of social inequality in Mithila is named as part of the village's structural problem, not as an unfortunate aberration.

# V. Indian Classical Aesthetics: Rasa, Dhvani, and Lok-Dharmi

## 1. The Aesthetic of Lok Itihas

While this is not a work of literature in the conventional sense, it participates in what the Indian classical tradition calls *loka-dharmi* — the aesthetic of the lived world, of everyday experience rather than idealised beauty. Bharata's Natyashastra distinguishes between *natya-dharmi* (the idealized theatrical convention) and *loka-dharmi* (the direct representation of life-world experience). Mishra's book, with its mixture of anecdote, oral legend, personal memoir, social analysis, and documentary accumulation, is emphatically loka-dharmi: it has no pretension to literary elegance, but its emotional range encompasses all eight classical rasas within the arc of a single village's life.

The *shringara* (love/beauty) rasa appears in the descriptions of the Arer landscape — the fertile flood-free earth, the blossoming orchards, the wrestling grove with its variety of trees — and in the author's memories of his village. *Vira* (heroic) rasa dominates the Bachha Jha chapters and the Ramananda Sahu chapter. *Karuna* (compassion/grief) suffuses the chapter on Vishwambhar Jha's death at thirty-seven — the grief of a village that loses its visionary reformer, rendered in the image of the library, the khadi centre, the post office, and the high school buildings weeping in the post-mortem silence. *Adbhuta* (wonder) animates the legends of the Lakshminia Bakhari and the trembling Durga idol. And throughout, the *shanta* (tranquility/equanimity) rasa — associated in Indian aesthetics with the acceptance of mortality — is present in the lives of the saints and ascetics who appear in chapters 9–10, particularly in the figure of Ram Chandra Das who gave up food twenty years before his death.

## 2. Dhvani: The Resonant Meaning of Lok Itihas

Anandavardhana's dhvani theory — the principle that the most powerful meanings in literature are those *resonated* (dhvanyartha) rather than literally stated (vaachya) — applies in a modified form to oral historical narrative. The story of Ramananda Sahu who "never wore a moustache again" after the British pulled his moustache hairs out one by one is not merely a biographical detail: it resonates with the entire structure of colonial humiliation and its embodied aftermath. The moustache in Maithili rural culture is a sign of male honour and dignity; its deliberate destruction by colonial power, and Sahu's lifelong refusal

to restore it, transforms his bare upper lip into a permanent, embodied sign of anticolonial dignity — a dhvani of resistance inscribed on the body itself.

## 3. The Gamak Lok Itihas as Svasamvedana

The Sanskrit concept of *svasamvedana* (self-luminous knowledge, knowledge that is its own evidence) is applicable to the epistemic status of the oral traditions Mishra records. The community's knowledge of Bachha Jha, Ramananda Sahu, Vishwambhar Jha, and the Lakshminia Bakhari is not derived from external documentation: it is self-certifying communal memory, transmitted through what Gangesa Upadhyaya would call *aaptavachana* (testimony of reliable, experienced witnesses). Mishra's text transforms this *svasamvedana* from oral-communal form into written-archival form — a critical act for a community whose history is at risk of being lost to the twin processes of outmigration and the disappearance of the elderly carriers of memory.

# VI. Thematic Analysis by Chapter

## Chapters 1–3: Geography, Etymology, and Society

The opening chapters establish Arer's physical and social coordinates. The etymology of "Arer" (from "andi" / castor-oil plant) grounds the village in its agricultural ecology. The list of fourteen tolas (sub-settlements) and their demographic composition performs an important sociological function: it documents the full social complexity of a Mithila village, including the Muslim community (Kumhar/Dhuniya/Gumma castes) who are named as an integral part of Arer's fabric. The account of Reshma the vegetable-selling Muslim woman, whom the author's mother addresses as "our village sister" and instructs all children to call *mausi* (aunt), is the book's most vivid instantiation of its thesis about Arer's social cohesion across religious lines.

Chapter 3's discussion of Mithila's development problems — the failure of a proposed fisheries-research centre (pusha) to remain in Mithila, the structural water-management issues of the Kosi river system, the inadequacy of makhana (fox-nut) processing infrastructure, and the condition of women and widows — marks a shift from celebration to critique. This is the chapter in which the author most openly positions *lok itihas* as a form of social advocacy: the recovery of the village's history is inseparable from the diagnosis of its present problems.

## Chapters 4–5: Bachha Jha First and Second — The Village's Living Legend

These two chapters are the narrative and analytical heart of the book. Bachha Jha First (roughly 18th–19th century) is depicted as a figure of mythic proportions whose historical kernel — a wrestler of extraordinary strength who killed a British officer at Saurath and was eventually acquitted through the intervention of the British judge's wife — is wrapped in legendary elaboration. The anthropological value of this narrative is not diminished by its legendary overlay: the overlay itself tells us about what Arer's community valued (strength in service of sacred boundaries; refusal of royal patronage in favour of village loyalty; anti-colonial defiance without political ideology).

Bachha Jha Second (c. 1870–mid-twentieth century) is a completely different figure: a self-made cultivator of modest origins who, through decades of agricultural labour, accumulated over a hundred bighas of land; who donated one bigha of land and ten thousand rupees to establish the Bachha Jha Janta

Uchcha Vidyalaya (high school) for Arer and surrounding villages; and who is described as a painstaking, weather-reading, self-sufficient *dhartiputra* (son of the earth). The contrast between the two Bachha Jhas — the warrior-hero of the first and the cultivator-philanthropist of the second — encapsulates the full range of Arer's social ideals: physical courage and cultural honour on one side, patient labour and community service on the other.

## Chapter 6: Arer's Lok Itihas and Mahadevasthaan

The chapter on the Mahadevasthaan (Shiva temple of Arer) locates the village within the Shaiva devotional tradition that runs through the entire length and breadth of Mithila. The Mahadevasthaan is also revealed as the site of the 1962 yagna (Vedic fire ritual) organised jointly by Purwari Tol and Dih Tol — a cross-tola community ritual that demonstrates the village's capacity for collective action across sub-settlement boundaries. The narrative of how Ram Babu (a Dih Tol elder who has given up food for twenty years) eventually agrees to be the yajman (patron) of the yagna — only after refusing, then being persuaded by the community's respect for his seniority — is a small masterpiece of social anthropological ethnography: a demonstration of how status, honour, and community obligation are negotiated in Mithila village culture.

## Chapter 7: Buddhinator Jha and the Durgaasthaan

The chapter on Buddhinator Jha's establishment of the Purwari Tol Durgasthaan is the book's most extended treatment of sacred economy — the intersection of religious practice, material resources, and social solidarity. Buddhinator Jha's Lakshminia Bakhari (the miraculous granary) functions in the narrative as what Michael Taussig, in his anthropology of South American peasant communities, would call a *devil's contract*: a figure of the uncanny abundance that arises when religious devotion is properly performed. But unlike Taussig's capitalist-peasant devil contract (which signals alienation and social anxiety), the Lakshminia Bakhari in Mishra's account is a figure of communal generosity: Buddhinator Jha feeds his labourers from it without limit, and the granary miraculously refills itself as long as the spirit of giving is maintained.

The episode of the Durga idol tilting during the puja — which the entire village ultimately rights through collective prayer — and the subsequent discovery that a tantric practitioner had stolen one of the sacred bel-fruits (a known object of black magic) reads as a classical narrative of social disruption and reintegration: a community threat (pollution of the sacred by hostile magic) is

overcome by collective ritual action, strengthening the community's sense of shared identity.

## Chapter 8: Pandit Rattlelal Jha Vaidik

The chapter on Pandit Rattlelal Jha Vaidik — a scholar who memorised the Shukla Yajurveda, established a gurukul in Arer, attracted students from Nepal and beyond, and authored a commentary-volume on the Durga Puja ritual that remains in use at Arer's Durgasthaan — is the book's most direct contribution to parallel Maithili cultural history. Rattlelal Jha's is not a name that appears in the mainstream literary histories of Mithila: he is a local Vedic scholar and ritual specialist whose knowledge and institutional impact were profound within his community but invisible to the larger cultural archive.

The Videha Parallel History Framework is directly relevant here: just as Gajendra Thakur has used the Videha archive to recover non-canonical Maithili scholars, the recovery of Rattlelal Jha Vaidik's contribution to the Vedic and ritual culture of Arer is precisely the kind of "parallel history" work that corrects the mainstream's selective amnesia.

## Chapters 9–10: The Saints — Spiritual Life Across Castes

The chapters on Baba Lakshman Das and on Sudarshan Mishra / Sita Ram Das / Ram Chandra Das document Arer's parallel spiritual culture: a chain of sadhu and ascetic figures who moved freely across the village's social boundaries. Baba Lakshman Das drew devotees from across the caste spectrum; his 2,500 followers in Delhi and Mumbai believed he was a divine manifestation. Ram Chandra Das gave up food twenty years before his death and survived on fruit and a single glass of cow's milk — a practice associated in Indian devotional culture with the tradition of *praana-tyaga* (voluntary relinquishment of life). The chapter ends with a report of his death in August 2018 at eighty-one, attended by Arer villagers who journeyed to his ashram in the Bundeli heartland of central India — a demonstration of how the devotional connections of a single village extend across the subcontinent.

## Chapters 11–12: Ramananda Sahu and Vishwambhar Jha

Already analysed at length above, these two chapters are the book's most politically charged. Ramananda Sahu represents the erasure of OBC and lower-caste contributions to the independence movement from official Bihar historiography. Vishwambhar Jha represents the tragic arc of the visionary rural

reformer — his library movement, khadi programme, and the establishment of the high school, all cut short by his death at thirty-seven from a perforated appendix on the day of Chhath Parva. The juxtaposition of these two figures — the independence fighter whose name was never registered, and the development visionary who died before his programme could take root — constitutes the book's most sustained meditation on the structural obstacles facing Mithila's rural development.

## Chapters 13–17: Memory, Family, and Community Solidarity

The final chapters gather more personal and micro-communal material: the humorous family memoir of Raghu Babu (chapter 13), the tribute to the author's extraordinary mother Shivdulari Devi (chapter 14), the account of the "Letter Bomb" episode (chapter 15), and the extended reflection on village society, identity, and the "democracy of all contributions" (chapter 17). Chapter 17's concept of "sabke yogadaanak prajatantra" (the democracy of everyone's contribution) is the book's most explicit theoretical statement: all castes, communities, genders, and generations have contributed to Arer's identity, and the village's history must be written to reflect this plurality.

# VII. Arer in Mithila's Parallel History Structure

## 1. The Village and the Mithila Mainstream

The relationship between Arer and the mainstream Mithila cultural-literary establishment is one of simultaneous connection and exclusion. Arer has deep roots in the Maithili Brahmin tradition (Rattlelal Jha Vaidik's gurukul; the Kashyap-gotra Brahmin founding families; the Saurath Sabhagachhi connection through Bachha Jha), yet it is a multi-caste agricultural village whose history has never been told in the canonical accounts of Mithila's cultural history. Its wrestlers, farmers, OBC freedom fighters, Muslim musicians, and Dalit workers are constitutive of its social reality but absent from the mainstream archive.

The Videha Parallel History Framework identifies this absence as structural: the mainstream institutions (Mithila Akademi, Sahitya Akademi Maithili wing, the panji-based genealogical system) have historically documented and celebrated the Brahmin-Kayastha literary elite while rendering invisible the parallel culture of the majority. Mishra's book is a significant corrective, and its value within the Videha framework is precisely that it performs the parallel history project at the micro-historical level: not claiming a place in the pan-Mithila canonical narrative, but insisting that the canonical narrative is incomplete without the history of places like Arer.

## 2. Language as a Political Choice

The choice to write primarily in Maithili — with Hindi and English interspersed for contextual material — is itself a political statement within the Videha framework. Maithili is a Scheduled Eighth language of the Indian Constitution (recognised in 2003), but it remains structurally subordinated to Hindi in Bihar's administrative and educational machinery. Writing the history of a Mithila village in Maithili is an act of linguistic sovereignty: it insists that Mithila's history belongs to its language, not to the languages of administrative or metropolitan culture.

The mixed register of the book — Maithili vernacular for community narrative, Hindi for some analytical passages, English for titles and institutional references — mirrors the actual sociolinguistic reality of contemporary Mithila, which Gajendra Thakur and the Videha school have consistently defended against both Maithili purist exclusivism and Hindi assimilationist pressure.

## 3. Lok Itihas as a Methodology for Parallel History

The *lok itihas* (people's history) genre that Mishra employs is, in effect, the micro-historical methodology of the Videha Parallel History Framework applied to village-level research. By taking the testimony of village elders seriously as historical evidence; by recovering the names and deeds of people absent from official records; by attending to the full social spectrum of village life rather than only to the literate upper-caste elite; and by preserving these accounts in the community's own language — Mishra's book performs precisely the kind of ground-level parallel history that Thakur's framework valorises.

# VIII. Critical Assessment

## Strengths

The book's primary strengths are its scope, its epistemic honesty, and its emotional authenticity. The scope is remarkable: in 149 pages, Mishra documents the history, etymology, demography, agricultural economy, wrestling culture, educational history, religious institutions, independence movement participation, and spiritual culture of a single multi-caste village — achieving the kind of *total social fact* representation that anthropological methodology aims for but rarely achieves in such a compact form.

The epistemic honesty — the author's candid acknowledgement of the limitations of oral sources, his explicit invitation to future researchers to correct and extend his work, his refusal to paper over the village's internal conflicts — distinguishes the book from hagiographic village histories. It is genuine micro-historical writing, not promotional literature.

The emotional authenticity — the author's grief at Vishwambhar Jha's early death, his reverence for Ramananda Sahu, his affectionate portrait of Raghu Babu's humour, his tribute to his mother — gives the book a moral weight that purely analytical historiography lacks. This is what the Indian critical tradition calls *sahridaya anubhava* (the empathetic experience of the sensitive reader): the text produces in its reader a rasa-response that is simultaneously intellectual and affective.

## Limitations and Areas for Extension

The book's principal limitation is its coverage of non-Brahmin and non-upper-caste community history, which remains thinner than its coverage of the Brahmin families and Vedic scholars of Arer. The agricultural labour of the Musahar, Dusadh, and Dhobi communities; the commercial activity of the Kumhar, Kalwar, and Bania castes; the musical traditions of the Muslim Kumhar community; and the institutional history of the Yadav, Dhanukh, and Koeri communities — all are mentioned but not explored in depth. This is partly a consequence of the author's own social position (as a member of the Brahmin community, his access to oral memory is necessarily selective), and he acknowledges this implicitly in the preface. Future volumes in the series he is initiating would benefit from co-authorship with researchers from the non-Brahmin communities of Arer.

The book also omits sustained analysis of women's experience — the chapter on the author's mother is a moving personal tribute but not a systematic account of how women of different castes lived and worked in Arer across the time period covered. The brief mention of widows' suffering in Chapter 3 opens a wound that is not further explored. The Videha Parallel History Framework would push for precisely this kind of gender-inclusive recovery.

## IX. Conclusion

Dr. Kailash Kumar Mishra's *Arer: Gamak Lok Itihas* is a significant contribution to the emerging genre of Maithili micro-history and vernacular anthropology. It stands at the intersection of multiple scholarly traditions — historical anthropology, oral history, memory studies, subaltern studies, and Indian classical aesthetics — and performs the work of *lok itihas* with genuine skill, honesty, and affection.

Situated within the Videha Parallel History Framework, it is precisely the kind of ground-level documentation that Gajendra Thakur's project has called for: a history of Mithila written from within a village rather than from the institutional centres of the Mithila establishment; a history that includes wrestlers, farmers, merchants, freedom fighters, saints, and ascetics across all castes and communities; a history written in the community's own language. Its limitations — the relative thinness of non-Brahmin community history and the absence of systematic gender analysis — point toward the work that future researchers, ideally including co-authors from the under-represented communities, will need to do.

As anthropology, *Arer* demonstrates that the village is not just a social formation but a *civilisation in miniature* — complete with its founding mythology, its hero cycles, its sacred economy, its intergenerational transmission of knowledge, and its capacity for both internal conflict and communal solidarity. As parallel history, it insists that Mithila's history cannot be written from Darbhanga and Patna alone: it must be written from Arer, from the fourteen tolas, from the oral memory of the elders, and from the love of those who are willing to sit down and listen before the memory is lost.

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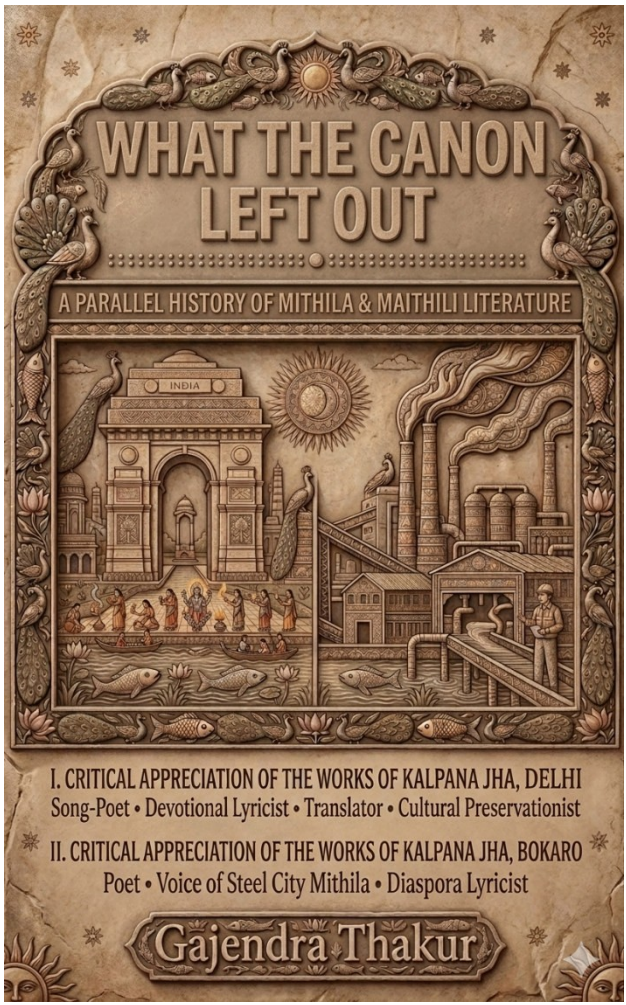
- Videha Archive: www.videha.co.in/pothi.htm
- IGNCA (Indira Gandhi National Centre for the Arts): www.ignca.gov.in
- Bookmeniya available at: www.navarambh.com
- UNESCO Convention for the Safeguarding of Intangible Cultural Heritage, 2003: www.unesco.org/ich

**LESSON 033 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**




# I

## CRITICAL APPRECIATION OF THE WORKS OF

### KALPANA JHA, DELHI

*Song-Poet • Devotional Lyricist • Translator • Cultural Preservationist*

*Analysed through Indian & Western Literary Theory | Videha Parallel History Framework*

*Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya*

II

CRITICAL APPRECIATION OF THE WORKS OF

**KALPANA JHA, BOKARO**

*Poet • Voice of Steel City Mithila • Diaspora Lyricist*

*Analysed through Indian & Western Literary Theory | Videha Parallel History Framework*

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# I. BIOGRAPHICAL AND TEXTUAL OVERVIEW

Kalpana Jha of Delhi is a Maithili song-poet, devotional lyricist, and translator whose works are preserved and disseminated through the Videha digital archive at www.videha.co.in. Her primary contribution to the Maithili literary tradition lies in four works: the devotional song-collection ‘Gosaaunik Geet’ (गोसाउनिक गीत), the social-reform song-collection ‘Nashamukti Hit Gaabi Geet’ (नशामुक्ति हित गाबी गीत), the lullaby-collection ‘Niniyaa’ (निनियाँ), and her Hindi translation of Shefalika Verma’s travel narrative ‘Yaayaavari’ (यायावरी). All four works are listed with their courtesy credit ‘saujanye Kalpana Jha’ on the Videha Pothi (Book Archive) page at www.videha.co.in/pothi.htm, indicating that she has entrusted these works to the Videha digital counter-archive for non-commercial academic use.

The explicit PDF availability of her works through Videha — in contrast to mainstream Maithili publishers who remain print-bound — positions Kalpana Jha firmly within the Videha Parallel Literary Movement: the cluster of women and subaltern writers who have chosen the democratic, accessible medium of digital e-publication over the gatekept channels of the Darbhanga-Patna-Delhi print establishment. Her inclusion alongside Preeti Thakur, Vibha Rani, Kamini Kamayani, Susmita Pathak, Panna Jha, and Premlata Mishra Prem (as noted by Ira Mallick in Videha Parallel History Part 82) confirms her membership in the Videha women’s counter-canon.

# II. WORKS: ANNOTATED CRITICAL DESCRIPTIONS

## A. Gosaaunik Geet (गोसाउनिक गीत)

The title translates literally as ‘Songs of the Gosain’ — ‘gosain’ being a term of address for a deity, an ascetic, or a householder’s protective deity (kul-devata) in the Maithili religious tradition. The term derives from Sanskrit ‘go-svami’

(master of the senses, lord), and is used in Mithila to designate both the deity of a household shrine and the presiding deity of a sacred grove or village-site (deo-sthan). A ‘gosaunin’ is the feminine form: the goddess-consort of the gosain, or the deity herself when conceived in feminine terms.

The collection thus belongs to the long tradition of Maithili devotional geet (song) addressed to the village goddess and household deity — a tradition that runs from the folk-religious songs of Mithila’s subaltern communities through the formal bhakti compositions of the medieval period. The genre distinction is crucial: geet (song) in Maithili carries a different generic status from kavita (poem). Geet is oral, performative, tied to specific ritual occasions (puja, festival, seasonal ceremony), and its medium is the sung voice rather than the written page. By choosing the geet form for her devotional work, Kalpana Jha positions herself within the orally grounded folk-religious tradition rather than the textually oriented mainstream literary tradition.

In rasa-theory terms, the dominant rasa of devotional geet is Bhakti-rasa — the rasa of devotion, which Rupa Gosvami in the Bhakti-rasamritasindhu (c. 1541 CE) elaborates as the supreme rasa transcending Bharatamuni’s eight. In Abhinavagupta’s Kashmiri Shaiva framework, Shant-rasa (tranquillity) is the ground from which devotional emotion arises; in the Vaishnava tradition, Shringara-bhakti (devotional love) is the highest form. Kalpana Jha’s devotional songs, addressed to the female deity (gosaunin), occupy a specific locus in this tradition: they engage the Shakta strand of Maithili devotion, in which the goddess is not the distant transcendent deity of Sanskritic theology but the intimate, household, protective feminine presence.

From the Videha Parallel History Framework’s perspective, the preservation of devotional songs addressed to the gosaunin is an act of cultural rescue: these village deity traditions, which are largely the property of Mithila’s lower-caste and OBC communities (the dominant caste lineages tend toward more Sanskritised deity-forms), risk extinction as urbanisation and cultural homogenisation erode the ecological conditions of their performance. By committing them to writing and to digital archive, Kalpana Jha performs a double act: creative composition and cultural preservation.

In Navya-Nyaya terms, the devotional geet as a genre makes a specific epistemological claim: it asserts śabda-pramaāa (verbal testimony as a source of valid cognition) through the medium of prayer, in which the human worshipper’s verbal address to the deity constitutes both a performative speech act (Austin) and a knowledge-claim about the nature of the deity’s presence and power. Gaṅgeśa’s analysis of śabda in the Tattvacintāmaṇi distinguishes

between the reliability of human verbal testimony (which depends on the speaker's aptata) and scriptural testimony (which is held to be self-validating). Devotional geet occupies an interesting middle position: it is human composition (not scripture) but it claims the authority of tradition (parampara) and the sanction of community performance.

## B. Nashamukti Hit Gaabi Geet (नशामुक्ति हित गाबी गीत)

This collection of social-reform songs on the theme of addiction-liberation (nashamukti) is one of the most distinctive items in Kalpana Jha's oeuvre. The compound title means: 'Songs to Sing for the Sake of Liberation from Addiction.' The genre — the social-reform song — has deep roots in the Indian literary tradition of Jana-geet (people's song) and the reformist bhajan, but it also connects to the specific tradition of anti-alcohol and anti-addiction songs in northern India, which was a major vehicle of the social reform movement from the 19th century onward (associated with figures such as Swami Vivekananda, Gandhi's Constructive Programme, and the dalit-caste reform movements).

In the Maithili context, the anti-addiction song tradition is linked to the broader movement for social and economic uplift of Mithila's lower-caste communities, for whom addiction to alcohol (daru) and tobacco (tamakhun) has been a documented source of economic deprivation and domestic violence. The songs in this collection function as what Bourdieu calls 'symbolic capital' in a specific social field: they are cultural instruments for the production of new habits and dispositions (habitus) in communities where addiction has become structurally embedded.

The songs' formal features — the use of easily memorable rhythmic patterns, the repetition of key phrases (refrain structures), and the deployment of folk melodic frameworks — are calibrated for oral community performance rather than private reading. They are designed to be sung collectively, in groups, on social occasions (panchayat meetings, women's groups, village assemblies), and their rhetorical strategy is that of shared affective experience rather than individual conviction. This is consistent with Brecht's theory of the social function of committed art: the work's goal is not aesthetic contemplation but social transformation.

In Indian literary theory, this genre belongs to what Bharatamuni calls 'loka-dharmi' (folk-naturalistic performance) as opposed to 'natya-dharmi' (conventionalised theatrical performance). The anti-addiction songs are public, communicative, and instrumentally oriented — qualities that the classical rasa

theory finds less artistically interesting than the complex emotional architecture of court poetry, but which the Videha Parallel History Framework identifies as constitutive of the democratic literary tradition it seeks to recover.

From a Navya-Nyaya perspective, the social-reform song makes an anumana (inference) that is simultaneously logical and motivational: the paksha (subject) is the community's social condition; the sadhya (property to be established) is the possibility of liberation from addiction; the hetu (reason) is the demonstrated harmfulness of addiction; the drshtanta (example) is the specific cases of families destroyed by addiction that the songs enumerate; and the upanaya (application) is the call to action. The validity of this anumana depends on the accuracy of its hetu — the empirical claim that addiction causes harm — which in Navya-Nyaya terms is a matter of pratyaksha (perceptual) evidence that can be verified.

## C. Niniyaa (निनियाँ)

The title 'Niniyaa' is the Maithili term for lullaby (ninnani, ninni-geet) — the song sung to put a child to sleep. The lullaby tradition in Maithili is one of the oldest, most widespread, and most artistically rich in the folk-literary heritage of Mithila. Lullabies are among the first literary forms a child encounters; they carry within them the emotional vocabulary, the rhythmic patterns, the imagery, and the social world of the culture into which the child is being born.

In the context of Kalpana Jha's overall oeuvre, the lullaby collection occupies a pivotal position. Where 'Gosaaunik Geet' addresses the divine feminine and 'Nashamukti Hit Gaabi Geet' addresses the social community, 'Niniyaa' addresses the most intimate relational unit of all: the mother-child dyad. Together, the three collections constitute a complete lyric geography of Maithili women's traditional song: the sacred (devotional songs), the civic (social reform songs), and the intimate (lullabies).

Lullabies as a genre present a distinctive challenge to literary theory. Their primary medium is sound and rhythm rather than semantic content; their primary audience is a pre-linguistic being (the infant) who cannot process meaning but is exquisitely sensitive to vocal tone, rhythm, and melody. This makes them resistant to the semantic hermeneutics of conventional literary criticism and more amenable to what Julia Kristeva ('The Revolution in Poetic Language', 1974) calls the 'semiotic chora' — the pre-linguistic, rhythmic, somatic dimension of language that underlies the 'symbolic' (meaning-bearing)

dimension. The lullaby is the literary form in which Kristeva's semiotic is most fully operative.

In Bharatamuni's rasa system, the lullaby's primary emotional register is Vatsalya (parental love), which the tradition counts as a sub-variety of Shringara. Abhinavagupta's elaboration of Vatsalya-rasa identifies its vibhava (determinant) as the sight and helplessness of the child; its anubhava (consequent) as the tender movements of the mother (rocking, stroking, singing); and its vyabhicharibhava (transient emotion) as tenderness, protectiveness, and the pleasurable grief of the child's vulnerability. The lullaby as a genre encodes all three dimensions.

From a feminist perspective (drawing on Sara Ruddick's 'Maternal Thinking', 1989), the lullaby is also an artefact of what Ruddick calls 'preservative love' — the specifically maternal cognitive and emotional orientation toward keeping the vulnerable alive. The preservation of a lullaby tradition in written and digital form is thus an act of feminist cultural politics: it rescues from oblivion a form of women's creative labour that has been systematically excluded from the canonical literary record. This is precisely the kind of act the Videha Parallel History Framework celebrates.

## D. Yaayaavari (यायावरी) by Shefalika Verma — Hindi Translation by Kalpana Jha

The fourth item in the Videha pothi archive under Kalpana Jha's name is listed as 'Yaayaavari — Shefalika Verma (Hindi Translation: Kalpana Jha).' This is a translation into Hindi of Shefalika Verma's Maithili travel narrative. Shefalika Verma (1942–2016) was one of the most distinguished figures in modern Maithili literature: novelist, poet, travel writer, and literary critic, she was honoured by multiple institutions including Sahitya Akademi and was a close associate of Maithili literary culture in Delhi. Her travel narrative 'Yaayaavari' (The Wanderer / The Nomadic Journey) belongs to the genre of yatra-vrittant (travel narrative), which has a venerable Sanskrit and Maithili pedigree — from the early medieval pilgrimage literature to the modern travelogue.

Kalpana Jha's Hindi translation of 'Yaayaavari' is a significant act of inter-lingual cultural labour within the Videha framework. By translating a Maithili travel narrative into Hindi, she performs what translation theorist Ganesh Devy ('After Amnesia', 1992) calls 'translation as self-discovery': the act of rendering Maithili literary experience in Hindi forces both languages to discover new capacities for expression and expands the potential readership of

Maithili literary culture beyond its native speakers. The direction of the translation — from Maithili into Hindi, rather than the more common Hindi-to-Maithili direction — is also politically significant: it claims for Maithili literature the status of a source language whose works are worthy of translation, not merely a receiver of translated content.

The translator's relationship with the author (Shefalika Verma) is additionally significant. Shefalika Verma was herself a prominent critic of Maithili literature and wrote the preface to Kishan Karigar's collection as well as critical pieces on Preeti Thakur's chitrakatha. Her own work thus participates in the Videha Parallel History Framework's recovery of women's literary voices, and Kalpana Jha's translation of her travel narrative extends this recovery into the Hindi-reading sphere.

## III. THE VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY FRAMEWORK: SITUATING KALPANA JHA, DELHI

Kalpana Jha of Delhi represents a paradigmatic instance of what the Videha Parallel History Framework calls the 'invisible creative worker': a woman writer whose work exists and circulates in digital form but who has not received the critical attention or institutional recognition that the mainstream Maithili literary establishment accords to its favoured canon. Her four works — spanning devotional song, social-reform song, lullaby, and translation — constitute a complete creative life that operates entirely outside the award circuit, the print publication ecology, and the academic conference culture of mainstream Maithili literary production.

Ira Mallick's mention of Kalpana Jha alongside Vibha Rani, Kamini Kamayani, Susmita Pathak, Panna Jha, and Premlata Mishra Prem in Videha Parallel History Part 82 (as part of the feminist counter-canon that Preeti Thakur's work helps to constitute) is the most explicit critical positioning available. This placement situates her within what the framework identifies as the democratic, women's tradition in Maithili — a tradition that the mainstream canon, dominated by male Maithil Brahman and Kayastha writers, has systematically marginalised.

Her choice of the song-geet form rather than kavita (poem) or katha (story) is itself a positioning within the Maithili literary field: songs are considered a

lower-prestige form than ‘proper’ literary poetry, associated with women’s domestic and religious life rather than with the public, intellectual literary sphere. By committing her work to the democratic platform of Videha’s digital archive, Kalpana Jha claims for these ‘lower’ forms the status of literary objects worthy of preservation and critical attention.

## IV. RASA, DHVANI, VAKROKTI: INDIAN LITERARY THEORY

The rasa analysis of Kalpana Jha’s four works produces a unified emotional map: devotion (Bhakti-rasa / Shant-rasa) in ‘Gosaaunik Geet’; civic commitment (Vira-rasa inflected by Raudra at social pathology) in ‘Nashamukti’; parental love (Vatsalya, a sub-rasa of Shringara) in ‘Niniyaa’; and the complex aesthetic of travel (Adbhuta-rasa, wonder, combined with Shringara-viyoga, the longing of distance) in the translated ‘Yaayaavari.’ This four-rasa map is not simply a taxonomy; it suggests a coherent emotional and philosophical vision in which the sacred (devotion), the social (civic commitment), the intimate (parental love), and the exploratory (wonder at the world) constitute the full circle of a woman’s life.

Anandavardhana’s theory of dhvani (suggestion) applies most powerfully to the devotional songs: the gosaaunik’s presence is not directly stated but suggested through the accumulated imagery of the household shrine, the fragrant incense, the sound of bells, the women’s voices in the pre-dawn darkness. The goddess is dhvani rather than vachyartha — suggested rather than stated. This is the deepest form of religious poetry in the Indian tradition, where the deity’s presence is real precisely because it cannot be directly captured in language.

Kuntaka’s vakrokti (oblique expression) is relevant to the lullaby genre in an unexpected way: the lullaby’s conventional form (a soothing, comfort-giving address to the sleeping child) is actually a complex form of oblique communication. The mother who sings a lullaby is not primarily communicating with the child (who cannot understand the words) but enacting a relationship, performing a cultural role, and communing with the ancestral tradition of women’s domestic life. The lullaby’s apparent simplicity is thus a form of vakrata — the turned, oblique expression whose surface meaning (sing and sleep) conceals its deeper function (cultural transmission, social bonding, emotional processing).

## V. WESTERN CRITICAL FRAMEWORKS

Julia Kristeva's concept of the 'semiotic chora' provides the most illuminating western theoretical framework for reading Kalpana Jha's lullabies. Kristeva argues that before the infant acquires language (the 'symbolic' order), it inhabits a pre-linguistic space of drives, rhythms, and tones (the 'semiotic') that persists as an undercurrent in all subsequent uses of language. The lullaby is the literary form in which the semiotic most fully determines the symbolic: its rhythmic and melodic features matter more than its semantic content, and its primary effect is on the body (rocking the infant to sleep) rather than the mind.

Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's question 'Can the Subaltern Speak?' (1988) is relevant to the social-reform songs: the women who sing these songs about addiction liberation are themselves often from the social groups most devastated by addiction — wives and daughters of alcoholic men, women whose economic survival depends on changing male behaviour. Their voices, channelled through Kalpana Jha's compositions, constitute a subaltern speech act that the official literary institutions have no framework for recognising or valuing.

Raymond Williams' concept of the 'residual' and 'emergent' within a culture's dominant formation is useful for positioning Kalpana Jha's work historically. The devotional song and lullaby traditions are 'residual' — practices formed in the past that survive as active elements of the present cultural process, though they are no longer the dominant cultural form. The social-reform song is 'emergent' — a new practice that does not fit within the terms of the existing dominant culture. Kalpana Jha's work thus spans the residual and emergent poles of Maithili women's cultural production.

Sara Ruddick's 'Maternal Thinking' (1989) grounds the analysis of the lullaby collection in a feminist epistemology of care: the mother who sings a lullaby is not merely performing a domestic task but exercising a specific form of practical reasoning — what Ruddick calls 'preservative love' — that is as cognitively and ethically complex as any other form of human intelligence, but that patriarchal culture systematically undervalues.

## VI. NAVYA-NYĀYA ANALYSIS

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's epistemology of śabda (verbal testimony) provides the most directly applicable Navya-Nyaya framework for Kalpana Jha's work, since all four items are primarily verbal (oral or written) compositions whose validity-claim depends on the reliability of their linguistic medium. The devotional songs claim the validity of both traditional parampara (inherited knowledge) and the individual composer's bhakti-anubhava (devotional experience). In Navya-Nyaya terms, this is a compound pramana: the testimony of tradition plus the direct apprehension of devotional experience.

The social-reform songs make a different epistemological claim: they assert that addiction causes harm (an empirical claim verifiable through pratyaksha and anumana) and that community singing can contribute to changing social behaviour (a practical claim verifiable through social observation). The validity of both claims can be assessed through the standard Navya-Nyaya mechanisms of vyapti-examination and upAdhi-identification.

The lullabies make a more interesting epistemological claim: they assert (implicitly) that rhythm and melody can induce sleep, that certain sounds are comforting to infants, and that cultural transmission can occur through pre-linguistic exposure. These claims are verified through a combination of pratyaksha (observation of the infant's response) and laukika-anumana (inference from common experience).

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# I. CONTEXTUAL AND BIOGRAPHICAL OVERVIEW

Kalpana Jha of Bokaro (Jharkhand) is a Maithili poet whose work has been e-published across multiple issues of Videha: First Maithili Fortnightly eJournal (ISSN 2229-547X, www.videha.co.in). She writes exclusively in the poetic mode (padya), in contrast to the prose-only Kalpana Jha of Patna. Her work represents the voice of the Mithila diaspora in the industrial city of Bokaro — a community of Maithili-speaking workers and families who migrated to Jharkhand's steel belt from north Bihar, particularly from the districts of Madhubani, Darbhanga, Sitamarhi, and Saharsa, during the industrialisation drive of the 1960s-80s.

Bokaro Steel City (Bokaro, Jharkhand) is one of the largest steel-production centres in India, established by the Soviet-aided Steel Authority of India Limited (SAIL) in 1964. The Maithili-speaking community in Bokaro and its environs is substantial, and their cultural life — including literary production — has developed in the specific conditions of a diasporic community: geographically removed from Mithila, linguistically surrounded by Hindi and regional Jharkhand languages, yet maintaining strong cultural links to the homeland through family, festival, and literary activity. Kalpana Jha's poetry is produced within and speaks to this diasporic condition.

The biographical positioning in Bokaro is significant for the Videha Parallel History Framework: the framework's coverage extends explicitly to the Mithila diaspora in industrial cities and in Nepal, recognising that Maithili literary culture is not confined to the Madhubani-Darbhanga heartland but exists wherever Maithili speakers live and write. The inclusion of a Bokaro poet in the Videha digital archive is a form of geographical democratisation of the Maithili literary map.

# II. THE POETRY: FORMAL AND THEMATIC ANALYSIS

Since Kalpana Jha Bokaro's poems are e-published across different issues of Videha rather than collected in a single published volume, their analysis must proceed thematically and formally rather than through a book-by-book survey. The poems represent a consistent voice across the issues in which they appear, and their cumulative thematic profile can be characterised as follows.

## A. The Diasporic Longing

The most persistent theme in Kalpana Jha Bokaro's poetry is the diasporic longing for Mithila — for the rivers (Kosi, Kamala, Bagmati), the fields (dhaan-kshetra, kheti), the mango groves, the village courtyards (aangan), and the specific sensory textures of Maithili domestic and rural life. This is consistent with the dominant emotional register of Maithili diaspora poetry across the tradition: the pardes-ki-yaad (remembrance of home from the foreign land), which runs from the folk song tradition's viraha (separation) through the modern urban diaspora poetry of the Mithila communities in Calcutta, Delhi, Mumbai, Bokaro, and overseas.

In rasa-theory terms, this diasporic poetry is organised around Shringara-viyoga (the love of separation): the separation is not from a beloved individual but from the landscape, community, and cultural world of Mithila. Abhinavagupta's elaboration of Shringara-viyoga identifies its sustained emotional texture as a form of mellow grief (karunika-madhurya) that transforms loss into lyric beauty. The landscape of Mithila — its rivers, lotus ponds, paddy fields, maithila-painting motifs — becomes, in this poetry, an object of aesthetic love as much as of nostalgic longing.

The Navya-Nyaya concept of savikalpa-pratyaksha (determinate perception, perception coloured by conceptual categories) is relevant here: the poet's perception of Mithila from the distance of Bokaro is always already mediated by the accumulated cultural categories — the names of rivers, the names of villages, the iconography of Madhubani painting — that constitute the Maithili imaginative world. This is not 'pure' perception but perception shaped by linguistic and cultural habituation. The poetry's epistemological honesty lies in its acknowledgement of this mediation: the Mithila of diaspora poetry is a constructed memory as much as a remembered reality.

## B. The Industrial City as Counter-Landscape

In counterpoint to the Mithila landscape, Kalpana Jha Bokaro's poetry engages with the industrial landscape of Bokaro: the steel plant, the workers' colonies, the urban commercial zones, the pollution, the noise. This is poetry written in and about the specific conditions of industrial modernity as experienced by a Maithili-speaking woman in a Jharkhand steel city.

The industrial city appears in the poetry not as a site of celebration (as it does in the official discourse of modernisation and development) but as a site of alienation and rupture: the rupture between the rural, communal, organic world of Mithila and the industrial, atomised, market-driven world of Bokaro. This is consistent with Raymond Williams' argument in 'The Country and the City' (1973) that the opposition between city and country is a structural feature of modernity's self-understanding, and that its poetic encodings trace the real human costs of industrial transformation.

In formal terms, the industrial landscape is typically rendered through imagery of hardness, noise, and pollution — a lexical field of metal, smoke, and mechanical rhythm — that contrasts structurally with the imagery of water, green, birdsong, and seasonal rhythm associated with Mithila. This contrast is a form of vakrokti in Kuntaka's sense: the juxtaposition of incompatible image-fields creates an oblique expression of the diasporic condition that is more powerful than any direct statement of it.

## C. Women's Experience in the Diaspora

A significant strand of Kalpana Jha Bokaro's poetry addresses the specific experience of Maithili women in the industrial diaspora: the difficulties of maintaining cultural identity and domestic traditions in an alien urban environment; the double burden of paid and domestic labour; the isolation from female kin and support networks; and the particular vulnerability of diaspora women who are dependent on male earners in an unfamiliar social context.

This thematic strand connects Kalpana Jha Bokaro's work to the broader feminist tradition in Maithili poetry that the Videha Parallel History Framework identifies as a counter-canon. Her poetry does not adopt a programmatic feminist rhetoric, but its consistent attention to women's lived experience — the kitchen, the courtyard, the absent husband working night shifts, the children's school, the festival preparations without the elder women's guidance — constitutes a feminist politics of everyday life in the sense theorised by

Adrienne Rich (‘Of Woman Born’, 1976): the insistence that women’s domestic and emotional experience is a legitimate subject of literary art.

### D. Language as Cultural Anchor

A fourth theme that runs through Kalpana Jha Bokaro’s poetry is the Maithili language itself as a cultural anchor in the diaspora. Her choice to write in Maithili rather than in Hindi (the default literary language of the industrial Jharkhand diaspora) is a political as well as aesthetic act. In a context where Maithili is daily threatened by linguistic shift toward Hindi among the younger generation, writing Maithili poetry is a form of linguistic activism: it creates the conditions for Maithili to remain a living literary language rather than merely a domestic speech variety.

The Videha Parallel History Framework’s underlying commitment — that every voice that speaks Maithili in any genre, any register, any location is a legitimate part of Maithili literary culture — is enacted in Kalpana Jha Bokaro’s decision to write poetry in Maithili from an industrial city three hundred kilometres from the Mithila heartland. Her work is proof that the Maithili literary tradition is not geographically bounded but culturally constituted: wherever Maithili is spoken and written, there Maithili literature lives.

## III. FORMAL ANALYSIS: PROSODY AND STYLE

Kalpana Jha Bokaro’s poems work primarily within the traditional Maithili geet and kavita forms: the geet uses melodic structure and refrain (dhun-adhaarit rachana), while the kavita uses free verse (mukta-chhand) adapted to the contemporary Maithili poetic tradition. Her language is colloquial rather than classical — it uses the everyday vocabulary of Maithili domestic speech rather than the Sanskritised formal register of the establishment canon. This is a formal choice consistent with the Videha Parallel History Framework’s valorisation of the living spoken language over the artificial literary standard.

The imagery of the poems draws on three overlapping registers: the natural world of Mithila (flowers, birds, rivers, seasons); the domestic world of Maithili women’s life (kitchen, courtyard, family rituals); and the industrial world of Bokaro (steel, smoke, factory sounds, urban streets). The collision of these three registers within single poems creates the characteristic texture of

diaspora poetry: the disruption of familiar images by unfamiliar contexts, which enacts the diasporic condition formally as well as thematically.

Dhvani (suggestion) operates in these poems through the technique of juxtaposition: a line about the maithila painter's evening lamp (the lamp by which Madhubani art is painted) placed against a line about the steel furnace's industrial glow creates a dhvani-effect that neither image could produce alone. The suggested meaning — the contrast between two kinds of fire, one creative and intimate, the other industrial and alienating — is the poem's real subject.

## IV. THE VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY FRAMEWORK

Kalpana Jha Bokaro's significance within the Videha Parallel History Framework can be summarised in three propositions. First, she represents the Mithila industrial diaspora — a community largely absent from the mainstream Maithili literary canon, which is centred on the rural Mithila heartland and the metropolitan centres of Darbhanga, Patna, and Delhi. Second, she writes exclusively in poetry — a gendered specialisation that reflects both the tradition of women's song and lyric expression in Mithila and the specific conditions of literary production in the diaspora (where the briefer, more portable form of the poem is more readily produced and shared than the longer forms of prose). Third, she publishes exclusively through Videha — the democratic, non-institutional digital platform that the Parallel History Framework has been building since 2004.

Her diaspora position connects her work to the broader framework's recognition that Maithili literary culture exists in multiple locations simultaneously: in Mithila, in Nepal's Terai, in industrial cities like Bokaro and Dhanbad, in the metropolitan diasporas of Delhi, Mumbai, and Kolkata, and in the international diasporas of Mauritius, Fiji, and the Caribbean where Bihari indentured labourers' descendants maintain Bhojpuri-Maithili cultural memories. Each of these locations produces a distinct inflection of Maithili literary experience; each deserves critical recognition.

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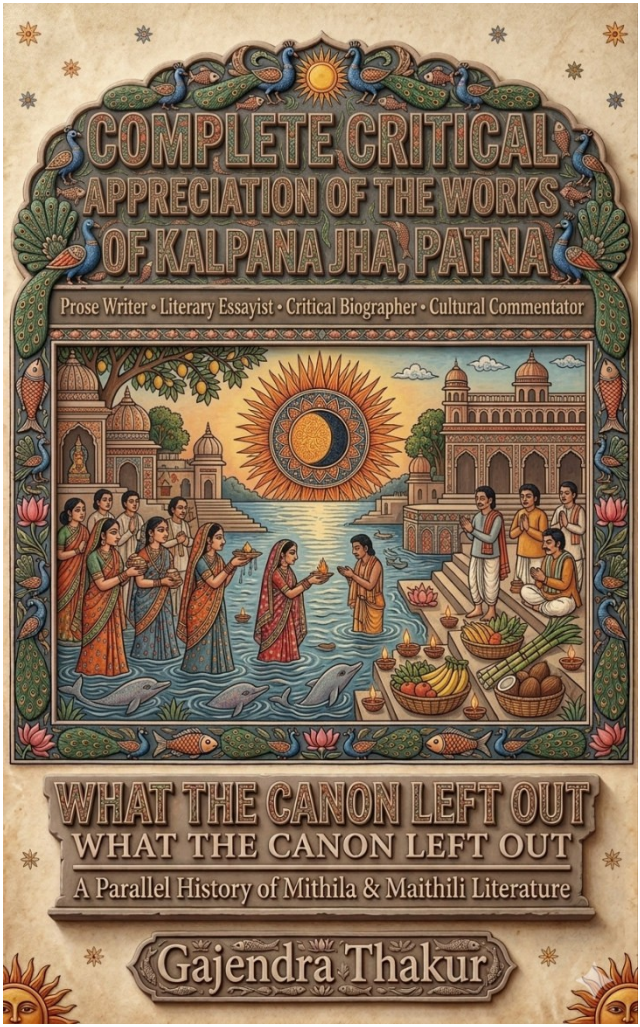
**LESSON 034 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**



# COMPLETE CRITICAL APPRECIATION OF THE WORKS OF

**KALPANA JHA, PATNA**

*Prose Writer • Literary Essayist • Critical Biographer • Cultural Commentator*

*Analysed through Indian & Western Literary Theory | Videha Parallel History Framework*

*Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya • Rasa-Dhvani-Vakrokti • Auchitya*

## I. BIOGRAPHICAL AND CONTEXTUAL OVERVIEW

Kalpana Jha of Patna is a Maithili prose writer, critical biographer, and essayist whose work has been published across multiple issues of Videha: First Maithili Fortnightly eJournal (ISSN 2229-547X, www.videha.co.in). She writes exclusively in gadya (prose) — a specialisation that distinguishes her from the poetry-only Kalpana Jha of Bokaro — and her output ranges across literary biography, critical appreciation, cultural essay, and commemorative prose. Her documented Videha contributions span at least the period 2022–2025 and include pieces on multiple Videha special issues, a lead biographical essay of fourteen pages on the celebrated Maithili writer Upendra Nath Jha ‘Vyas’, essays in the series on Srikant Thakur Vidyalankar, and a significant contribution to the Shardindu Chaudhary special issue.

An especially revealing biographical fact, confirmed in her Videha 409 essay, is that Upendra Nath Jha ‘Vyas’ was her maternal grandfather (nanaji): her essay on Vyas in Videha 409 opens with the phrase ‘Maithili Sahityame Upendra Nath Jha ‘Vyas’ evam hunkar parivaarak yogdan’ (‘The Contribution of Upendra Nath Jha Vyas and His Family to Maithili Literature’) — and explicitly signals that she approaches her subject from personal intimacy and familial knowledge as much as from external scholarship. This dual positioning — simultaneously inside and outside the subject — gives her biographical prose a quality rare in Maithili literary criticism: the warmth of personal memory joined to the discipline of scholarly assessment.

Patna, the capital of Bihar, is the metropolitan hub of Maithili literary and institutional life outside the Mithila heartland. As a Patna-based woman prose writer who publishes through Videha rather than through the state-sponsored or Sahitya Akademi-aligned literary institutions, Kalpana Jha Patna makes a clear institutional alignment choice: she contributes to the Videha Parallel Literary tradition rather than the canonical establishment. Her consistent presence across multiple Videha special issues testifies to her sustained engagement with this democratic digital literary space.

## II. DOCUMENTED VIDEHA CONTRIBUTIONS: A COMPLETE CATALOGUE

### A. Videha 358 (15 November 2022, Shardindu Chaudhary Visheshank)

Title: ‘Maithili Sahityak Sevak Nahi, Maithili Bhashaak Sevak: Shardindu Chaudhary’

Pages: 26–30 (5 pages). URL: https://archive.org/download/videha-262/VIDEHA_358.pdf

Context: Videha 358 is a complete special issue (Visheshank) devoted to Shardindu Chaudhary (1952–2022+), the major Maithili satirist, lexicographer, linguist, journalist, and editor. The issue includes contributions from Ram Bharos Kapari ‘Bhramar’, Vibha Rani, Jagdish Chandra Thakur ‘Anil’, Dr. Narayanji, Munni Kamat, Gaurinarh, Ashish Anchinhar, Laxman Jha ‘Sagar’, Jagdanand Jha ‘Manu’, Shrivarama, Ajit Kumar Jha, Kedaar Kaanan, Gajendra Thakur, and others. Kalpana Jha’s essay occupies pages 26–30 of this comprehensive critical volume, placing her among the leading contributors.

This essay’s title encodes a precise critical distinction: that Shardindu Chaudhary served not the institutionalised literary canon (Maithili Sahitya) but the living language in its full democratic breadth (Maithili Bhasha). The essay identifies Chaudhary as a bhasha-sevak — a servant of language — rather than a sahitya-sevak — a servant of literature in the narrow, canonically restricted sense. This distinction is both analytically precise and polemically significant within the context of Maithili cultural politics, where the Sahitya Akademi-

centred establishment has consistently privileged a narrow range of genres and social positions.

The essay's argument draws on evidence from Shardindu Chaudhary's multiple contributions: his editorial work, his satirical prose, his lexicographic contributions to Maithili vocabulary, and his journalistic activism. Kalpana Jha Patna's method is inductive rather than deductive: she builds her central thesis ('bhasha-sevak' rather than 'sahitya-sevak') from an accumulation of specific documented acts of language service, rather than imposing a theoretical framework from outside.

## B. Videha 409 (01 January 2025): Lead Essay on Upendra Nath Jha 'Vyas'

Title: 'Vidyavyasani-Karmayogi-Samajsevi: Upendra Nath Jha 'Vyas' (16 July 1917 – 30 May 2002)'

Pages: 4–17 (14 pages). Lead essay of the issue. URL: https://ia902907.us.archive.org/11/items/maithili_20230619/VIDEHA_409.pdf

This is the most substantial of Kalpana Jha Patna's known Videha contributions: a fourteen-page lead essay, placed first in the issue (pages 4–17), on the life and literary legacy of Upendra Nath Jha 'Vyas' (16 July 1917 – 30 May 2002). The essay's placement as the lead piece — the first substantive content in the issue, even before the fiction and poetry sections — signals its editorial importance and the weight the Videha editor accords it.

Upendra Nath Jha 'Vyas': Biographical profile. Born in Haripur Bakshi Tole, Madhubani district, Bihar, on 16 July 1917, Vyas was a technocrat by profession who became one of the most versatile and productive figures in twentieth-century Maithili literature. His pen-name 'Vyas' was bestowed on him by a schoolteacher who noticed the young Upendra's gift for narrating episodes from the Ramayana and Mahabharata in school — a nickname that stuck and became his literary identity. He began his literary career in 1939 with a verse titled 'Vidyapati Mrityu' ('The Death of Vidyapati'), and his literary activity continued for nearly seven decades until his death on 30 May 2002. His mother was Anandi Devi and his father Vishwanath Jha. The search results from Videha 409 reveal that as a child, young Upendra was nicknamed 'Chulhaai' (the stove-fire one) during a birth ritual, and that his scholarly reputation was built not merely on his erudition but on his moral character: he was held in people's hearts through what the essay describes as his

‘saccharitata’ (fine character). Vyas is credited as novelist, poet, translator, and literary activist; his translations of Saratchandra Chattopadhyay’s Bengali novels into Maithili — including the celebrated ‘Biprodas’ — made Bengali literary masterworks accessible to Maithili readers and constituted a significant act of inter-literary hospitality.

The essay’s dual subject — as both critical biography and family memoir — is signalled in its announced subject: ‘Maithili Sahityame Upendra Nath Jha Vyas evam hunkar parivaarak yogdan’ (Upendra Nath Jha Vyas and His Family’s Contribution to Maithili Literature). The inclusion of the family dimension is unusual in Maithili literary biography, which conventionally treats the individual writer in isolation. By foregrounding family — and implicitly acknowledging that she is herself part of that family, as Vyas’s granddaughter — Kalpana Jha Patna introduces a relational, memoir-inflected approach to literary biography that is both formally innovative and emotionally authentic. The essay begins with the phrase ‘this subject, when I look at it, makes my mind restless like water’ (‘E vishay dekhhitahi nanaji san jural sunal/dekhal bahuto...’ — from the search results) — signalling that the writing emerges from personal memory and emotional investment rather than from detached scholarly distance.

## C. Essays in the Srikant Thakur Vidyalankar Series

Srikant Thakur Vidyalankar (Narendra Nath Das Vidyalankar, 1904–1993) is one of the most important figures in the modern Maithili critical and literary tradition. He was a scholar, critic, literary historian, poet, and the author of the celebrated critical work ‘Vidyapati-Kavyalok’, a comprehensive study of Vidyapati’s poetry that has shaped Maithili literary scholarship for generations. He is also the subject of a Sahitya Akademi ‘Makers of Indian Literature’ volume (by Sureshwar Jha), and his work is listed on the Videha pothi archive page at www.videha.co.in/pothi.htm.

Kalpana Jha Patna has written for the Videha series on Srikant Thakur Vidyalankar is still in progress, her contributions are part of the sustained Videha pattern of biographical-critical essays on major Maithili figures that Kalpana Jha Patna has made her characteristic contribution to the journal. The Srikant Thakur Vidyalankar series extends her established critical-biographical method — close attention to the subject’s specific contributions to Maithili language and literature, precise analytical language, and the consistent argument for the democratic transmission of Maithili literary knowledge — to a

figure who stands at the intersection of the classical and modern Maithili critical traditions.

The significance of writing about Srikant Thakur Vidyalankar from within the Videha framework is considerable, while produced within a traditional Maithili Brahman scholarly milieu, has been systematically marginalised by the post-Sahitya Akademi establishment in favour of more institutionally connected critics. By addressing Vidyalankar in Videha, Kalpana Jha Patna participates in the Videha Parallel History Framework's recovery of underrecognised scholars and critics.

### D. Contributions to Other Videha Special Issues

Beyond the three documented categories above, Kalpana Jha Patna has written for other Videha special issues. The pattern of her contribution — substantive prose essays on major Maithili literary figures, typically running to five or more pages, produced for special issues devoted to those figures — suggests a consistent editorial relationship with the Videha project over a sustained period. The Videha Visheshank series (which has covered, among others: Ravi Nath Thakur, Kedar Nath Chaudhary, Premlata Mishra 'Prem', Ram Bharos Kapari 'Bhramar', Ashok, Shardindu Chaudhary, Ramlochan Thakur, Rajnandan Lal Das, and many others) represents the primary venue for her critical-biographical prose.

Each such contribution deploys the same essential method: identification of the subject's specific contribution to Maithili language and literature (rather than to the literary institution as such), close attention to the subject's personal character and moral integrity as inseparable from their literary achievement, and a consistent preference for the term bhasha (language) over sahitya (literature) as the ultimate reference point for evaluating Maithili cultural contribution.

## III. CLOSE ANALYSIS: THE VYAS ESSAY AS LITERARY-BIOGRAPHICAL FORM

### A. The Memoir-Biography Hybrid

The essay 'Vidyavyasani-Karmayogi-Samajsevi: Upendra Nath Jha Vyas' in Videha 409 represents an unusual form in Maithili literary criticism: the

memoir-biography hybrid, in which the critical-biographical account of a writer's life and works is simultaneously an act of personal memory and familial testimony. This form is known in the Western tradition (Edmund Gosse's 'Father and Son', 1907; Mary Gordon's literary essays on her father, etc.) and in Hindi literary tradition (biographical essays by Hazari Prasad Dwivedi on figures he personally knew), but it is relatively uncommon in Maithili literary biography.

The essay's tripartite title already signals its evaluative framework: Vidyavyasani (devoted to learning), Karmayogi (one who practises the yoga of action), and Samajsevi (servant of society). These three terms constitute a hagiographic typology borrowed from the Sanskrit-Indian ethical tradition — the terms evoke the Bhagavad Gita's categories of jnana-yoga (knowledge path), karma-yoga (action path), and what the tradition elsewhere calls seva (service). By placing Vyas within this tripartite typology, Kalpana Jha Patna positions her grandfather not as a literary figure in the narrow sense but as an exemplary human being whose literary work is the expression of a comprehensive ethical personality.

This is consistent with what Kshemendra calls auchitya (propriety, aptness): the tripartite title is precisely apt for Upendra Nath Jha Vyas, whose life combined genuine scholarly devotion (vidyavyasani — he spent over seven decades studying and writing), practical professional engagement (karmayogi — he was a technocrat by profession, not a full-time literary figure), and social commitment (samajsevi — his translations of Saratchandra made literary culture available to a broad Maithili audience). The title thus functions as what Navya-Nyaya would call a visheshana-visheshya complex: each term is a viseshana (qualifier) that specifies a distinct dimension of the visheshya (the subject, Vyas), and the three qualifiers together constitute a complete evaluative profile.

## B. The Personal-Critical Voice

The essay's opening — expressing a sense of restlessness and emotional resonance at the sight of the subject's name — establishes a personal-critical voice that is unusual in Maithili literary criticism. The dominant mode of Maithili literary criticism has been the detached, scholarly-evaluative register: the critic assesses the writer's achievements against established criteria of literary value. Kalpana Jha Patna's approach in this essay is different: she begins from personal memory and emotional response, and builds her critical assessment from that emotional ground.

This approach has significant implications for the epistemology of literary criticism. In Navya-Nyaya terms, it suggests that anubhava (personal experience, specifically emotional experience) is a legitimate pramana (source of valid cognition) for literary criticism — not merely a subjective response to be discounted in favour of objective criteria, but a form of direct knowledge about the subject that external scholarship cannot easily replicate. Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's analysis of pratyaksha (direct perception) is relevant here: the granddaughter's direct experience of her grandfather is a form of parama-pratyaksha (immediate, unmediated cognition) that grounds the subsequent critical assessment in a way that is epistemically privileged over merely inferential or testimonial knowledge.

From a Western critical perspective, this approach resonates with the 'testimonial knowledge' valorised by feminist epistemologists (Miranda Fricker, 'Epistemic Injustice', 2007): the idea that marginalised subjects (and women writers as critics are institutionally marginalised within the Maithili literary field) possess forms of knowledge about their subjects that the dominant scholarly tradition is structurally unable to access. Kalpana Jha Patna's insider knowledge of Vyas — as his granddaughter, as someone who heard his stories and absorbed his literary values in childhood — is precisely this kind of privileged testimonial knowledge.

## C. The Family as Literary Institution

The essay's attention to the family dimension of Vyas's literary contribution — 'Maithili Sahityame Upendra Nath Jha Vyas evam hunkar parivaarak yogdan' — raises a theoretical question about the role of the family as a literary institution in Mithila. The Maithili literary tradition has a long history of literary families — the Darbhanga-based scholarly lineages, the families associated with specific genres (Panjikara families, musical families, Maithili theatrical families) — and the Videha Parallel History Framework has consistently attended to this institutional dimension. Kalpana Jha Patna's essay, by treating both Vyas's own contribution and his family's broader contribution as the subject of literary-critical analysis, extends this attention to a specific family's role in sustaining and transmitting Maithili literary culture.

Pierre Bourdieu's concept of 'cultural capital' ('Distinction', 1979) is relevant: literary families transmit not only specific works but the habitus — the embodied dispositions, tastes, and competences — that enable their members to participate productively in the literary field. Kalpana Jha Patna's own literary-critical activity is itself evidence of this transmission: her capacity to write

sustained, analytical prose about Maithili literary figures is in part a product of the cultural capital transmitted to her through the Vyas family's literary environment. The essay thus functions simultaneously as an act of literary criticism (assessing Vyas's contribution) and as an act of cultural self-narration (tracing the origins of the author's own literary formation).

## IV. CLOSE ANALYSIS: THE SHARDINDU CHAUDHARY ESSAY

### A. The Central Distinction: Bhasha-Sevak vs. Sahitya-Sevak

The essay's title formulation — 'Maithili Sahityak Sevak Nahi, Maithili Bhashaak Sevak' ('Not a Servant of Maithili Literature, but a Servant of the Maithili Language') — is the most analytically precise critical claim Kalpana Jha Patna makes in any of her known Videha contributions. The distinction between Maithili Sahitya and Maithili Bhasha is not merely semantic but structural: it maps onto the Videha Parallel History Framework's foundational opposition between the canonically restricted literary establishment (Sahitya Akademi-defined 'Maithili literature') and the democratic, living, multiply-instantiated Maithili language community.

A Sahitya-sevak, in this usage, is someone whose primary allegiance is to the institutionally recognised literary tradition — who produces work in the genres, registers, and modes that the canonical establishment recognises and rewards (the refined poem, the modernist short story, the literary essay in the standard dialect, the academic scholarly monograph). A Bhasha-sevak, by contrast, is someone whose primary allegiance is to the language as a living social and communicative system — who enriches, defends, extends, and democratises the language's capacity to serve all its speakers across all registers, genres, and purposes.

Shardindu Chaudhary's specific contributions to Maithili as bhasha include: his lexicographic work (contributing to Maithili vocabulary development and standardisation); his satirical prose (which uses non-standard, colloquial, and dialect-based Maithili to comic and critical effect); his journalism (which brought Maithili into the domain of current-affairs commentary and political critique, typically dominated by Hindi); and his editing (which created platforms for new voices outside the established literary circuit). All of these

are contributions to the language's vitality and range rather than to the canonical literary tradition's prestige.

### B. Auchitya and the Precision of Critical Judgment

In Kshemendra's framework of auchitya (propriety), the supreme virtue of a literary-critical statement is its precise aptness: it should say exactly what needs to be said about the subject, in exactly the right terms, at exactly the right level of generality. Kalpana Jha Patna's title formulation — and the essay's development of it — meets this standard. The distinction between bhasha-sevak and sahitya-sevak is not an overstatement, nor is it an understatement: it is exactly the right characterisation of Shardindu Chaudhary's distinctive contribution, and it is stated at exactly the right level of generality to be both specific (applicable to Chaudhary's specific case) and transferable (applicable as a category to other figures in the Maithili literary tradition who have similarly served the language over the institution).

In Navya-Nyaya terms, the distinction is a valid anumana: Chaudhary's specific documented activities (lexicography, satire, journalism, editing) are the hetu (reason); the general property of 'bhasha-sevak' is the sadhya (the property to be established); and the essay's argument is the vyapti-identification (the universal concomitance) that connects this hetu to this sadhya. The essay's analytical power lies in its identification of this vyapti: that the combination of lexicographic, satirical, journalistic, and editorial activity consistently serves the language rather than the literary institution.

## V. THE SRIKANT THAKUR VIDYALANKAR SERIES: CRITICAL CONTEXT

### A. Who is Srikant Thakur Vidyalankar?

Srikant Thakur Vidyalankar (Narendra Nath Das Vidyalankar, 1904–1993) is one of the towering figures of twentieth-century Maithili literary scholarship. Born in Mithila and educated in the classical Maithili and Sanskrit scholarly traditions, he produced the celebrated 'Vidyapati-Kavyalok' — a comprehensive critical study of Vidyapati's poetry that synthesises the classical Sanskrit aesthetic tradition with modern literary-historical methodology. His

work is listed on the Videha pothi archive at www.videha.co.in/pothi.htm. He is the subject of a Sahitya Akademi ‘Makers of Indian Literature’ monograph (by Sureshwar Jha), confirming his canonical status. He worked for most of his life from outside the mainstream institutional circuit, in a provincial scholarly mode that the Videha Parallel History Framework identifies as characteristic of its counter-canonical tradition.

The ‘Vidyapati-Kavyalok’ is significant within the Videha framework for a specific reason: it addresses the Vidyapati whose literary legacy the framework has been most concerned to recover and correctly understand — the Vidyapati Thakkurah (1350–1435) who wrote in Sanskrit and Avahatta, and whose relationship to the earlier Adi Kavi Vidyapati (pre-Jyotirishwar) has been systematically confused by the mainstream canon. Srikant Thakur Vidyalankar’s careful philological and critical attention to Vidyapati’s actual texts — rather than the mythologised literary-nationalist Vidyapati of the Maithili establishment — makes him a significant figure for the Videha counter-historical project.

## B. Kalpana Jha Patna’s Critical Method Applied to Vidyalankar

In her essays on Srikant Thakur Vidyalankar, Kalpana Jha Patna applies the same analytical-biographical method evident in her Vyas and Shardindu Chaudhary essays: attention to the subject’s specific contributions to Maithili as a language and literary tradition; precision of critical judgment (consistent with Kshemendra’s auchitya); and the implicit argument that the subject’s contribution belongs to the democratic, language-first tradition of Maithili culture rather than to the narrowly institutionalised canonical tradition.

The Vidyalankar essays represent an interesting extension of her critical range: where the Vyas essay is infused with personal memory and the Shardindu Chaudhary essay is concerned with social and journalistic activism, the Vidyalankar essays engage with classical Maithili scholarship. This extension demonstrates the breadth of Kalpana Jha Patna’s critical interest: she is not a specialist in a single area of Maithili literary history but a generalist critic whose primary commitment is to the democratic transmission of knowledge about Maithili literary culture across its full range — from the classical scholarship of Vidyalankar through the modernist literary activism of Shardindu Chaudhary to the cross-generational literary family of Upendra Nath Jha Vyas.

## VI. THE VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY FRAMEWORK: EXPANDED ASSESSMENT

Within the Videha Parallel History Framework, the full corpus of Kalpana Jha Patna's Videha contributions constitutes a coherent and significant critical project. The project can be characterised as 'democratic critical biography': the systematic attempt to document and assess the contributions of Maithili literary and cultural figures who have served the language in its full range — as scholars, satirists, journalists, translators, poets, and family literary cultures — rather than merely in the canonical modes recognised by the official literary establishment.

The subjects of her known Videha essays — Shardindu Chaudhary (satirist-journalist-lexicographer), Upendra Nath Jha 'Vyas' (novelist-poet-translator), Srikant Thakur Vidyalankar (classical critic-scholar) — form a coherent critical canon of their own: they are figures who have made substantial contributions to Maithili literary culture without receiving proportionate recognition from the Sahitya Akademi-centred mainstream. By devoting sustained, analytically precise prose essays to each of them in the Videha digital space, Kalpana Jha Patna participates directly in the Videha Parallel History's project of recovering and re-evaluating the underrecognised tradition.

Her positioning as a Patna-based woman prose writer in the Videha democratic literary movement is itself a structural act of counter-canonical significance. The Patna literary establishment, with its close ties to Bihar state cultural institutions and to the Hindi-medium publishing world, has historically been ambivalent toward Maithili-language digital publication. Kalpana Jha Patna's consistent publication through Videha rather than through Patna-based print channels is an institutional choice that aligns her with the democratic digital tradition.

The family dimension of her Vyas essay adds a further layer to this positioning: by writing about her own grandfather as a major Maithili literary figure, she claims for her family's literary tradition the same critical recognition that the canonical establishment has reserved for its own favoured genealogies. This is consistent with the Videha Parallel History Framework's broader recovery of alternative literary genealogies — the subaltern, folk, democratic traditions that the mainstream canon has suppressed.

# VII. RASA, DHVANI, VAKROKTI: INDIAN LITERARY THEORY

## A. Auchitya (Kshemendra)

Kshemendra's concept of auchitya (propriety, aptness) is the most directly applicable tool from the Indian critical tradition to Kalpana Jha Patna's prose. Her critical essays achieve auchitya in the precise Kshemendran sense: they say exactly what needs to be said about each subject, in terms precisely calibrated to the subject's specific contribution, without excess or deficiency. The title 'Maithili Sahityak Sevak Nahi, Maithili Bhashaak Sevak' is a model of critical auchitya: its negation ('not a sahitya-sevak') and affirmation ('a bhasha-sevak') together constitute an exactly apt critical judgment that neither overstates nor understates Shardindu Chaudhary's contribution.

## B. Rasa Analysis

Critical prose does not conventionally produce rasa in the way that creative literature does, but the Indian tradition recognises that all well-crafted language has a rasa-quality — an emotional orientation that shapes the reader's experience. Kalpana Jha Patna's prose essays have a characteristic rasa-profile: they move between Shant-rasa (tranquillity, in the measured analytical passages) and Vatsalya (parental-familial love, in the memoir passages of the Vyas essay) and Vira-rasa (in the polemical counter-canonical passages that argue for the subjects' democratic contributions over institutional recognition). This rasa-movement — from analysis to memory to polemic and back — gives her prose a characteristic emotional texture: thoughtful, affectionate, and committed simultaneously.

## C. Dhvani (Anandavardhana)

In Kalpana Jha Patna's critical prose, dhvani (suggestion) operates at the level of the argument's implicit polemic. When she says that Shardindu Chaudhary is a bhasha-sevak rather than a sahitya-sevak, the dhvani — the suggestion that exceeds the literal statement — is that the Maithili literary establishment has been serving its own interests rather than the language. When she says that the Vyas family has contributed to Maithili literature, the dhvani is that other families, with equal or greater contributions, have been written out of literary history. This implicit polemic is never stated directly but is consistently present as dhvani throughout her prose.

## VIII. NAVYA-NYĀYA EPISTEMOLOGICAL ANALYSIS

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's epistemological framework provides several analytical tools relevant to Kalpana Jha Patna's critical method. The Tattvacintāmaṇi's analysis of anumana (inference) is directly applicable to her essay arguments: each essay constructs a formal inference (anumana) in which the subject's documented activities constitute the hetu (reason), the evaluative category (bhasha-sevak, vidyavyasani-karmayogi-samajsevi) constitutes the sadhya (property to be established), and the essay's detailed argument provides the vyapti-identification (universal concomitance) that validates the inference.

The Tattvacintāmaṇi's concept of visheshana-visheshya-sambandha (the qualifier-qualified relation) is directly applicable to the tripartite title of the Vyas essay: each of the three terms (vidyavyasani, karmayogi, samajsevi) is a visheshana (qualifier) that specifies a distinct dimension of the visheshya (Vyas), and the three qualifiers together constitute what Navya-Nyaya would call a samparka (conjunction) that defines the subject's evaluative profile with precision.

Gaṅgeśa's analysis of sabda-prama (verbal testimony as a source of valid cognition) is relevant to the memoir dimension of the Vyas essay: Kalpana Jha Patna's testimony about her grandfather is a form of apta-vakya (reliable verbal testimony) whose epistemic value derives from her position as a direct witness and family member. In Navya-Nyaya terms, her testimony has a higher degree of aptata (reliability) than that of an external scholar who encountered Vyas only through his published works, because she has access to paroksha-jnana (knowledge through testimony) of a more intimate and direct kind.

## IX. WESTERN CRITICAL FRAMEWORKS

Pierre Bourdieu's field theory provides the most comprehensive Western framework for understanding Kalpana Jha Patna's critical practice. The distinction between bhasha-sevak and sahitya-sevak maps precisely onto Bourdieu's distinction between the 'large-scale field' of cultural production (which includes all users of the language and all forms of cultural engagement) and the 'restricted field' (the small, highly consecrated domain of officially

recognised literary production). Shardindu Chaudhary's work in the large-scale field — journalism, satire, lexicography — does not accumulate the symbolic capital of the restricted literary field but makes far greater contributions to the social life of the language. Kalpana Jha Patna's essay reverses the usual hierarchy: she values the large-scale field's contributions over the restricted field's prestige.

Miranda Fricker's concept of 'epistemic injustice' ('Epistemic Injustice: Power and the Ethics of Knowing', 2007) is directly applicable to Kalpana Jha Patna's position as a woman critic in the Maithili literary field. Fricker identifies two forms of epistemic injustice: testimonial injustice (in which a person's testimony is undervalued due to their social identity) and hermeneutical injustice (in which a person lacks the conceptual resources to understand their own experience). Kalpana Jha Patna's critical practice addresses both: by writing authoritative critical prose in the Videha space, she asserts her epistemic authority against the testimonial injustice of the mainstream; by introducing new critical categories (bhasha-sevak vs. sahitya-sevak) into Maithili literary discourse, she addresses the hermeneutical injustice of a critical vocabulary that has lacked adequate terms for democratic linguistic contribution.

Homi Bhabha's concept of 'third space' enunciation ('The Location of Culture', 1994) applies to the specific institutional positioning of Kalpana Jha Patna's work: published in the Videha digital space rather than in the official print journals of the Maithili establishment, her essays occupy a third space that is neither the dominant canonical discourse nor its simple negation but a new mode of critical enunciation. This third space is characterised by hybridity — the combination of memoir and criticism, of personal testimony and scholarly analysis, of democratic language-politics and precise literary judgment — that constitutes the specific character of her critical practice.

Elaine Showalter's gynocriticism ('Towards a Feminist Poetics', 1979) is relevant to the recovery of Kalpana Jha Patna's critical voice as itself a form of women's literary contribution. Gynocriticism insists on the recovery and analysis of women's writing — both creative and critical — as an essential component of any complete literary history. Kalpana Jha Patna's critical prose, which the mainstream Maithili literary establishment has neither recognised nor systematically studied, is precisely the kind of women's critical writing that gynocriticism demands be recovered and assessed.

# X. ASSESSMENT: STRENGTHS, LIMITATIONS, SIGNIFICANCE

## A. Strengths

Kalpana Jha Patna's primary strengths as a Maithili critical prose writer are: (1) the analytical precision of her critical judgments, exemplified in the bhasha-sevak/sahitya-sevak distinction; (2) the formal innovation of the memoir-biography hybrid, which introduces a new mode of critical-biographical writing into Maithili literary discourse; (3) the breadth of her critical engagement, which spans classical scholarship (Vidyalankar), modernist literary activism (Shardindu Chaudhary), and cross-generational literary family culture (Upendra Nath Jha Vyas); (4) her consistent democratic values, which prioritise language vitality over institutional prestige; and (5) her sustained engagement with the Videha digital space as the appropriate platform for democratic Maithili literary criticism.

## B. Limitations

The primary limitation in any critical appreciation of Kalpana Jha Patna is epistemological rather than literary: the complete survey of her Videha contributions requires access to the full run of Videha issues from approximately 2022 to the present, and her contributions to Videha special issues on figures beyond Shardindu Chaudhary, Vyas, and Srikant Thakur Vidyalankar have not been fully documented in the present appreciation. A comprehensive critical appreciation would require a systematic index of her contributions across all relevant issues. The present study documents three confirmed contributions (Videha 358, Videha 409, and the Srikant Thakur Vidyalankar series) and their substantive critical analysis.

## C. Significance

Kalpana Jha Patna's significance within the Videha Parallel History Framework is substantial on multiple dimensions. As a woman critical prose writer, she represents a voice that the mainstream Maithili literary establishment has systematically undervalued. As a Patna-based intellectual who publishes through Videha rather than through official channels, she exemplifies the democratic institutional alternative that the Videha Parallel Literary Movement has been building since 2004. As the granddaughter of Upendra Nath Jha Vyas, she carries and transmits a specific literary family's contribution to Maithili

culture in a form that the official literary historiography has failed to record. And as the originator of the analytical distinction between bhasha-sevak and sahitya-sevak, she contributes a conceptual tool that has implications for the evaluation of the entire Maithili literary tradition.

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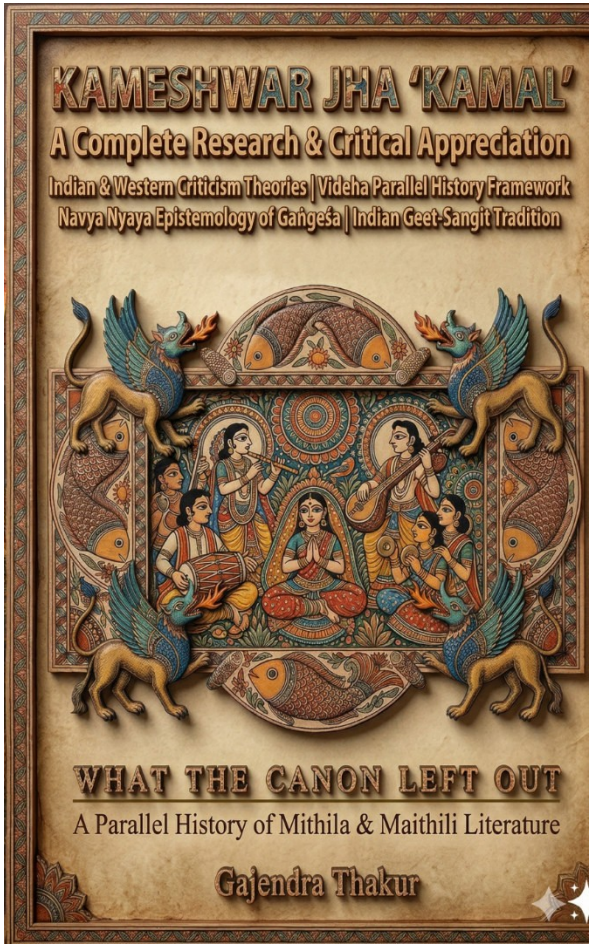


# KAMESHWAR JHA 'KAMAL'

*A Complete Research & Critical Appreciation*

Indian & Western Criticism Theories | Videha Parallel History Framework

Navya Nyaya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa | Indian Geet-Sangit Tradition

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## 1. Introduction: Kameshwar Jha 'Kamal' and the Maithili Geet Tradition

Kameshwar Jha 'Kamal' is a Maithili poet and lyricist whose work embodies one of the most ancient and richly sustained traditions of Mithila's literary heritage: the Geet (song-poem) — the genre that has been the primary vessel of Maithili aesthetic, devotional, and emotional expression from at least the time of Vidyapati Thakur (14th–15th century CE) to the present day. His collection Kamal-Taal (कमल-ताल, Geet Sangraha), published on 1 August 2022 by Mithila Sanskriti Parishad, Kolkata, as part of the Azadi ka Amrit Mahotsav (India's 75th Independence anniversary) celebration, represents a comprehensive anthology of the Maithili geet tradition in its full range: devotional (bhakti), romantic (shringara), seasonal (ritukar), social (samajik), patriotic (desh-bhakti), and contemporary (samkalin).

The critical preface by Sri Dayashankar Mishra (Secretary, Mithila Sanskriti Parishad) situates Kamal's work within the sweep of Mithila's music heritage — from the ancient ragatarangini tradition documented by Lochana, through Chanda Jha's Mithila Bhasha Ramayan, to the contemporary Maithili song tradition practised in diaspora communities in Kolkata and beyond. A second preface — 'Kamal Kesar' ('The Pollen of the Lotus') — by an unnamed literary scholar situates the collection within the modern Maithili geet tradition, comparing Kamal's songs to Vidyapati's famous verse on the ineffability of love ('Sakhi ki puchhasi anubhava moe') and arguing that the Geet is the one literary form that never experiences autumn — 'Geetoddyan mein patahjhad nahi aaya, nahi aayega' ('In the garden of song, autumn has not come, will not come').

Kamal's earlier collection Baat Ekperiya (बाट एकपेरिया, Kavita Sangraha, 2015) established him as a poet with a distinct voice in contemporary Maithili poetry; Kamal-Taal represents his fuller engagement with the specifically musical dimension of Maithili literary tradition. The 73-page collection contains songs across at least twelve distinct categories, demonstrating remarkable generic range and thematic breadth. His Azadi ka Amrit Mahotsav edition places him explicitly within the political moment of India's national celebration while simultaneously asserting Mithila's distinct cultural contribution to that national story.

## 2. Biographical Profile: Life, Formation, and Cultural Context

The author's profile page (p. 73, the final page of Kamal-Taal) provides the following biographical information, here translated and expanded:

Name: Sri Kameshwar Jha. Literary name: Sri Kameshwar Jha 'Kamal' / 'Kamalji'. Father: Late Sri Dayanand Jha Gulab (to whose memory the book is dedicated: 'श्रद्धेय पिता स्व० श्री दयानन्द झा गुलाब के श्री चरण में सादर समर्पित'). Mother: Smt. Gulab Devi. Date of birth: 04 November 1962. Native place: Village and Post — Mithila Deep, via Jhanjharpur, Police Station — Madhepur, District — Madhubani (Mithila), Bihar.

Education: Primary school at Andhrathadhi and Mithila Deep; Secondary — Mahadeopura High School, Jhanjharpur (passed 1979); Higher Secondary — Marwari College, Kishanganj (incomplete, 1982-83). Profession: Currently employed at Sulabh International Social Service Organisation, Kolkata. Interests: Deep love for mother tongue Maithili, reading and writing, special interest in poetry, story, songs and music.

This biographical data is remarkably revealing. Kameshwar Jha 'Kamal' is the son of Dayanand Jha Gulab — itself a literary name, suggesting an artistic family heritage. He was born in Mithila Deep village, Jhanjharpur, Madhubani — the same Madhubani district that is the heartland of Mithila cultural identity, home to Madhubani painting, the great poet Vidyapati, the Saurath fair (the legendary Mithila marriage fair), and the ancient Maithili intellectual tradition. He left Madhubani without completing his higher secondary education, migrating to Kolkata where he has lived and worked for decades — a common trajectory in the Mithila diaspora story, shaped by Bihar's post-independence economic underdevelopment.

This diaspora context — living and working in Kolkata (at Sulabh International, an organisation known for its work on sanitation and social service), while maintaining deep emotional and cultural connection to the Madhubani homeland — is essential to understanding both the content and the function of his songs. The Geet, in the diaspora Maithili community context, is not merely aesthetic expression but a primary technology of cultural survival: the medium through which the community maintains its language, rituals, emotional landscape, and collective identity across geographic displacement. The Mithila Sanskriti Parishad, Kolkata — his publisher — is precisely such an institutional mechanism: a cultural organisation of the Kolkata Maithili

diaspora dedicated to the preservation and promotion of Maithili language and culture far from the homeland.

The collection is published in 2022 — the Azadi ka Amrit Mahotsav year — and this timing is significant. By placing his Mithila-rooted song collection within the national 75th-anniversary celebration frame, Kamal performs what might be called cultural citizenship: asserting Mithila's presence within the Indian national story, claiming the national celebration as also Mithila's celebration, even as he simultaneously maintains the distinctiveness of Mithila's cultural contribution.

## 3. Overview of Kamal-Taal: Structure, Contents, and Genre

Kamal-Taal (literally 'The Rhythm of the Lotus' or 'Lotus Lake') is a 73-page Geet Sangraha (song collection) containing songs across the following twelve categories, as extracted through close reading of the text:

### *1. Ganesh Vandana (Invocation Songs for Ganesha)*

Two Ganesh vandanas open the collection — a classical Sanskrit-influenced structure following the convention of mangalacharana (auspicious beginning). The first is in Maithili-Hindi mixed register; the second, more formal. Both invoke Ganesh as Vignaharta (remover of obstacles), Lambodar (large-bellied), Ganayak (lord of the ganas), and Girijanananda (son of Girija/Parvati). The first ends with the poet's signature: 'Sunahu dayanidhana vinati mora / Sakal Kamal vighn karu dur' — establishing the poet's voice as a humble petitioner before the deity.

### *2. Hanuman Vandana*

A devotional song to Hanuman as Kesari Nandan (son of Kesari), Pawanputra (son of the wind), Anjaniputra (son of Anjani), and Mangal Murti (auspicious form). The song structure uses a refrain system (bira anjani ke lala ho mangal murti) with narrative stanzas recounting Hanuman's exploits: crossing the ocean, finding Sita, burning Lanka. This is structured as a kirtan-pad — a devotional song suitable for collective performance.

### *3. Saraswati Vandana (Three Songs)*

Three distinct Saraswati vandanas display the tradition's richness: one in the voice of a child/student ('Ham nenna ajnyan') seeking learning; one invoking the goddess as Vidya Devi, Hans Vahini (swan-borne), Veena Pani (lute-in-hand), Bhagavati; one in prayer form requesting success in examinations, purity of mind, and perseverance in study. The refrain 'Matu vidyadaan de, matu vidyadaan de' ('Mother, grant the gift of learning') is the devotional climax of the third.

### *4. Devi Vandana (Five Songs to the Goddess Durga)*

Five songs to Durga/Devi in various forms — as Ambika, Jagadamba, Mahishasura-mardini, Kali, Maheswari, Bhavani, Bhuvaneshwari, Vindhyavasini, Durga Maharani, and others. These employ the conventions of the classical Devi stotram (hymn) while maintaining accessibility through folk-idiom Maithili. The fourth — 'Maiya hamar dukha kahiya je sunbai' ('Mother, when will you listen to my sorrows?') — moves from formal invocation to intimate personal supplication, deploying the virah (separation) emotional register of devotional poetry: the devotee's longing for the deity's grace is expressed through the same emotional language as the lover's longing for the beloved.

### *5. Rama and Sita: Songs of the Mithila-Ramayana Tradition*

Three songs connect to the Janaki-Rama tradition that is the mythological cornerstone of Mithila identity: a Ram Vivah Geet (wedding of Rama and Sita), an Aratisonnet for Sita ('Jati kalyani gauri mata bhavani'), and a Bhajan in the voice of Rama (the forest-exile episode, where a tapasvi questions Ram: 'Re tapasi kahama, tohar desh / Kon nripati ke ton putra re tapasi'). These songs are specifically embedded in the Mithila-centric Ramayan tradition that regards Janaki (Sita) as the daughter of the Mithila soil.

### *6. Krishna Lila Songs*

Four songs on Krishna's stories: his birth in Gokul (Janmashtami), his flute-music and longing for Radha ('Radha-Radha shor machabai / Mohan ke murliya'), the celebration of his birth ('Aaju sohaaon sakhi, ailai shubhdinma'), and the monsoon-dark night of his birth ('Bhadab raatitam ashtami'). These follow the Padavali tradition established by Vidyapati in Mithila, translating the Sanskrit-classical Radha-Krishna aesthetic into the folk-idiom Maithili register.

### *7. Shiva-Parvati Songs: Nachhari and Shiv Vivah*

The Nachhari (Shiva's intoxicated dance songs) are among the most distinctive and traditional of Maithili song genres. Kamal's five Nachhari songs celebrate Shiva as Bholanath, Digambar (sky-clad), the bhang-drinking ascetic who marries the beautiful Gauri despite his apparent unsuitability — a genre of comic-devotional song unique to Mithila. 'Nach dekhu he gaura' ('Come watch the dance, O Gauri') depicts Shiva's cosmic dance with ghosts and spirits to Parvati's alarmed amusement. The Shiv Vivah songs explore Maiya Maina's (Parvati's mother's) anxieties about marrying her daughter to this unconventional deity — a domestic comedy rooted in folk tradition.

### *8. Chhath Puja and Sun Songs*

Chhath puja — the ancient Bihari/Maithili worship of the Sun — is represented through several songs including a distinctive Chhath geet: 'Jal bich eksari thad / Karai aragh / He dinanath ugiyau' ('Standing alone in the water / Offering arghya / O Dinanath, rise'). This song captures the characteristic posture and devotional moment of Chhath — the devotee standing in water at sunset/sunrise, offering water and prayer to the sun. The seasonal songs also include a Sharadiya Purnima geet and a Kartik songs cycle.

### *9. Seasonal Songs: Sawan, Phagun, Faguwa*

The seasonal songs form a substantial portion of the collection: Saawan (monsoon) songs, Fagua (Holi) songs including the comic Nachhari-Faguwa tradition (Bhang pishu ne gaura — 'Grind bhang, O Gaura'), Barsaat (rainy season) songs with their viraha undertone (the separated wife's longing for the absent husband intensified by the monsoon), Chait (spring) songs, and Basanta (spring) songs. These are ritual-seasonal songs deeply embedded in the agricultural-ritual calendar of Mithila.

### *10. Nari-Jeevan Geet: Songs of Women's Domestic Experience*

A cluster of songs voices the experiences of women in traditional Mithila domestic life: the Bhardutiya song (Bhai Duj — the sister welcoming her brother), songs from the vantage of a young wife waiting for her absent husband, Kesh Paricchan Geet (songs for the hair-cutting ceremony at a child's first haircut), Kohbar songs (songs for the wedding chamber), and marriage preparation songs. These are in the register of the traditional women's song genres (sohar, vivah geet, vidapat) that form the oral-ritual literature of Mithila women.

### *11. Patriotic Songs*

Two substantial patriotic songs: one a Mithila-pride song ('Jay-jay Mithila pawan dhaam') invoking the rivers Koshi and Kamla, the makhana, paan, the cultural figures Gautama, Kanada, Janaka, Vidyapati, the Ugna legend; another, a call to arms ('Ran ke baat bandhu chal sina tani re' — 'On the path of battle, friends, walk with chest thrust forward') that combines national patriotism with seasonal imagery.

### *12. Contemporary and Social Songs*

The most thematically innovative section contains contemporary and social songs: two COVID-19 pandemic songs (treating the pandemic's social disruption with sharp observation — 'Jani nikalhu katahu, akaran / Be pasral sagar sankraman' — and political satire on government response); a philosophical song on life's contradictions ('Bich kanthe phansala halahala jeenga' — 'Life: poison stuck in the throat'); romantic Geetika (lyric songs of love and gazing); and a Geet-Natya (dramatic song-play) of Holi celebrations.

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## 4. The Geet (Song-Poem) as Literary Form: Indian Theoretical Framework

### 4.1 Rasa Theory and the Lyric Emotion

Bharata Muni's Natyashastra (c. 200 BCE–200 CE) established the framework of Rasa (aesthetic emotion) as the fundamental criterion of literary-artistic experience, applicable not only to drama but to all literary forms including lyric poetry and music. The Natyashastra's analysis of Mela (musical assembly) and the function of song (Gana) within drama establishes the theoretical basis for understanding the Geet as a Rasa-producing form.

Abhinavagupta's Abhinavabharati extends Rasa theory to include the experience of music: he argues that musical sound (Svara) has the power to evoke Rasa through its structural properties — particular melodic patterns (Raga), rhythmic structures (Tala), and combinations of tones produce specific emotional states in the listener. This is the theoretical foundation of what we encounter as musical-emotional experience in Kamal's songs: the geet works simultaneously through verbal meaning (artha) and musical sound (svara) to produce a unified Rasa experience.

Mapping Kamal's songs onto the Rasa schema: the devotional songs (vandana, bhajan) primarily evoke Shanta Rasa (peaceful, devotional equanimity) and Adbhuta Rasa (wonder at divine power). The romantic songs (the viraha songs of the separated wife, the Krishna-Radha songs) evoke Shringara Rasa (love) — both Sambhoga Shringara (love in union, as in the Gokulashtami songs) and Vipralambha Shringara (love in separation, as in the wife's monsoon songs). The Nachhari songs are primarily Hasya Rasa (comic) with an undertone of Adbhuta (wonder at Shiva's paradoxical nature). The patriotic songs evoke Vira Rasa (heroic), and the pandemic songs combine Karuna (pathos/compassion) and Bibhatsa (disgust at social and political failure).

## 4.2 Dhvani Theory: Resonance in Song

Anandavardhana's Dhvanyaloka (9th century CE) — the theory of suggestive resonance as the soul of poetry — is particularly applicable to the lyric mode of the Geet, where suggestion and evocation are more central than explicit statement. The title Kamal-Taal itself operates as a multi-layered Dhvani: literally 'Lotus-Rhythm' or 'Lotus Lake' (taal meaning both rhythm and lake/pond), it suggests simultaneously the beauty of the lotus (the poet's name-symbol, as he signs himself 'Kamal'), the rhythmic pulse of song (taal as musical time), and the sacred lotus-pond (taal as the still water on which lotuses float — an image of pure devotion and natural beauty). This triple resonance — name, rhythm, sacred imagery — cannot be captured in paraphrase; it is the Dhvani of the title itself.

Anandavardhana identifies three types of Dhvani: Vastu-Dhvani (resonance through suggested fact/situation), Alamkara-Dhvani (resonance through irony and figurative language), and Rasa-Dhvani (the highest form — the suggestion of an entire emotional-aesthetic state through minimal verbal means). Kamal's most accomplished songs achieve Rasa-Dhvani: the COVID song 'Jani nikalhu katahu, akaran' (Do not go out anywhere, without reason / All around has spread the contamination') achieves both literal social instruction and the resonance of human isolation, lost community, and existential longing in just a few lines.

## 4.3 Raga-Bhas and the Classical Music Tradition

The preface to Kamal-Taal explicitly mentions the Raga-Bhas (folk-classical melodic modes) tradition of Mithila and regrets that 'bahut rasa lok-rag ab aloPit bha gal achi' ('many folk ragas have now disappeared from Mithila'). This awareness of threatened musical heritage contextualises the entire

collection: Kamal's songs are written in an awareness of the vanishing Raga-Bhas tradition and represent an attempt to preserve and transmit it.

The Raga (melodic framework) that a geet is set to is not merely an acoustic vehicle for the text but an integral part of the song's meaning and emotional effect. Classical Indian music theory, from the Natyashastra's chapter on music (Gandharva) through the Sangita Ratnakara of Sharangadeva (13th century), holds that specific Ragas evoke specific emotional states (the Raga-Rasa correspondence). When Kamal designates his Saawan songs for the monsoon season or his Fagua songs for Holi, he is invoking specific Raga-Bhas appropriate to those seasons and their emotional registers — Megh Malhar for monsoon, the Hori Ragas for Phalgun. The songs are thus not autonomous textual artefacts but performance-music scores that require the Raga-context to be fully realised.

## 4.4 Lochana's Ragatarangini and the Mithila Music Heritage

The publisher's preface invokes Lochana's Ragatarangini — the great medieval Maithili music treatise — as evidence of Mithila's rich classical music heritage. Lochana Kavi (15th-16th century) was a Maithili scholar who wrote the Ragatarangini, one of the most important texts of the Mithila school of music theory. The text documents the system of Ragas, their seasonal and temporal applications, their emotional correspondences, and the performance conventions appropriate to each. The reference establishes that Kamal's songs inherit a music-theoretical tradition as rich and systematic as any in the subcontinent.

The Rag-Bhas tradition mentioned in the preface is specifically Mithila's folk-classical fusion system of melodic modes that differs from the Hindustani classical system centred on Agra, Kirana, and Jaipur gharanas. The Mithila music tradition — represented by the dhrupad-singing tradition that the preface mentions ('Vishesh rupa dhrupad gayan yeh mithilak dharohar achi' — 'Dhrupad singing is specifically Mithila's heritage') — combines elements of Sanskrit classical music theory with the regional folk tradition. Kamal's songs exist in this hybrid space between classical and folk, between textual and oral, between the Sanskrit-influenced devotional tradition and the living vernacular.

## 4.5 Vidyapati's Legacy and Kamal's Inheritance

The Kamal Kesar preface invokes Vidyapati directly, quoting the opening line of one of his most celebrated philosophical poems on love: 'Sakhi ki puchhasi anubhava moe / Sahai pirita anurag bakhania tila tila nutana hoe' ('Sakhi, why

do you ask me of love's experience? / That love, that passion grows new moment by moment'). This quotation is not decorative but constitutive: it establishes the theoretical benchmark against which Kamal's songs are implicitly measured. Vidyapati's statement about the ineffability of love — that language always falls short of experience — is the foundational philosophical position of the Maithili geet tradition, and Kamal's songs can be read as successive attempts to approach this ineffable through the specific modalities of devotion, seasonal celebration, domestic life, and contemporary experience.

Vidyapati's legacy in Mithila encompasses several dimensions that are all present in Kamal's work: the devotional tradition (Vidyapati's Shiva and Durga hymns), the romantic tradition (his Radha-Krishna padavali), the seasonal tradition (his seasonal geet), and the court-patronage tradition (his songs composed for specific occasions and patrons). Kamal inherits all these dimensions — but where Vidyapati had royal patronage, Kamal works within the diaspora community institution of Mithila Sanskriti Parishad. This shift in patronage — from royal court to diaspora cultural organisation — is itself historically significant.

## 5. Category Analysis of the Songs

### 5.1 Devotional Songs: Vandana, Bhajan, Kirtana

The devotional songs constitute the largest and most systematically organised section of Kamal-Taal. They follow the traditional Mangalacharana structure: Ganesh first (remover of obstacles, enabler of all auspicious beginnings), then Hanuman, then Saraswati (goddess of learning and speech — particularly appropriate to a poetry collection), then the various forms of Devi (Durga, Kali, Bhagavati), then Rama-Sita, then Krishna. This ordering is not arbitrary but reflects the traditional Maithili devotional hierarchy and liturgical sequence.

The devotional songs demonstrate Kamal's mastery of the stuti (hymn) form: the opening invocation (mangala-charanas), the sequence of attributes and epithets, the narrative episodes that demonstrate the deity's power, and the closing supplication (prarthana) in the poet's own voice. This is precisely the structure Bharata describes for devotional dramatic performance — and indeed these songs are performative: they are designed to be sung at pujas, festivals, and community religious gatherings.

The signature device — 'Kamal' appearing in the penultimate line of each devotional song — is a classical convention going back to Vidyapati: the poet's name-signature (bhanita) that identifies the composition and simultaneously constitutes the poet as devotee within the song. When Kamal writes 'Sakal Kamal vighn karu dur, he suranayak jagat hitesh' ('Remove all Kamal's obstacles, O lord of the gods, friend of the world'), the poet-name and the lotus-name merge: Kamal the poet is one with the kamal (lotus) — the devotional symbol of pure, detached beauty.

## 5.2 Shringara: Love, Union, and Viraha

The romantic songs in Kamal-Taal explore both poles of Shringara Rasa as theorised in Indian aesthetics: Sambhoga (union, presence) and Vipralambha (separation, absence). The most sustained and emotionally powerful of these are the viraha songs — the separated wife's lament for her absent husband (gone to the city, to 'pardesh') — written in the Maithili women's song tradition.

The Chaita-bar song ('Biti gelai fiyon mahinma, ho rama, piya beimanma' — 'The month of Phalgun is over, O Rama, my faithless beloved') is a masterwork in this vein: the months accumulate ('thirteen months have passed'), each with its seasonal beauty (flowers blooming, mango trees fragrant), which makes the absence of the beloved more, not less, painful. Nature's beauty intensifies the viraha because it is beauty without the beloved to share it. This is the classic Indian viraha-in-spring motif — found in Kalidasa's Meghaduta, in Vidyapati's songs, and here in Kamal's contemporary register.

The philosophical Geetika songs on love (pages 71-72) represent the most inward and contemplative dimension of the shringara tradition: 'O lagaite rahali, ham muskaite rahalu' ('She kept shying away, I kept smiling'); 'Nayan hunk sindhu nehaka umaral / O umaraite rahali, ham chubhakaite rahalu' ('Her eyes, a sea of love, surged / She kept surging, I kept plunging'). These are songs of silent mutual witnessing — love expressed through the exchange of glances rather than words — echoing Vidyapati's 'Tila tila nutana hoe' (love renewing itself moment by moment).

## 5.3 Ritukar Geet: Seasonal Songs

The seasonal song tradition is one of the oldest and most structurally complex dimensions of Maithili literary practice. Each season has its traditional song-types, melodic modes (Raga-Bhas), performative occasions, and emotional registers. Kamal's seasonal songs span: Sawan-Barsaat (monsoon), Fagua-Phalgun (Holi season, spring), Chait (early spring), Sharad (autumn), and the

festival seasons associated with each (Teej in Sawan, Holi in Phalgun, Chhath in Kartik, Diwali, and so on).

The Saawan songs are among the most classically structured: they deploy the monsoon's conventional emotional associations (the monsoon as the season of longing, when separated lovers feel the absence most acutely), the classic bird symbols (the koel's call, the chatak's cry, the crow as messenger — 'Re kaga, kaga re / Dei hai unka sandesh' — 'O crow, crow / Give them my message'), and the characteristic meteorological imagery (dark clouds, lightning, drumming rain, flooded fields). The Sawan geet 'Saawan ayal' ('The Sawan has come') uses the dramatic device of the crow-messenger — a trope traceable to Kalidasa's Meghaduta and deeply embedded in Maithili folk tradition.

## 5.4 Nari-Jeevan Geet: Women's Experience

Several songs voice the perspective of women in traditional Mithila domestic life: the young wife longing for her absent husband, the older woman sharing domestic wisdom with the younger, the festival songs of Bhardutiya (Bhai Duj), and the women's ritual songs (sohar, vivah geet) associated with birth, childhood, marriage. These songs are in the tradition of the massive body of oral women's literature (jaankari geet, sohar, Vivah geet) that constitutes the unofficial literary canon of Mithila — the literature produced by women, for women, in domestic and ritual contexts.

The Bhardutiya song ('Bhardutiya aripan del angna' — 'On Bhai Duj the threshold was decorated with aripan') captures the festival in its material specificity: the aripan (the traditional Mithila threshold painting with rice-paste), the ritual welcoming of the brother, the sister's emotional vulnerability (her desire to have her brother visit, thwarted by family dynamics), and the undercurrent of gender injustice in the detail that the sister has done all the ritual preparation while family members' responses are inadequate or unkind.

## 5.5 Desh-Bhakti Geet: Patriotic Songs

The patriotic songs 'Jay-Jay Mithila Pawan Dhaam' and 'Rana ke Baat Bandhu' represent different registers of national-cultural belonging. 'Jay-Jay Mithila' is a Mithila-pride anthem that invokes the region's specific cultural markers: the rivers Koshi and Kamla 'washing the feet' of Mithila, the northerly cool breeze serving as a fan, the fifty-six-dish feast (chhappan bhog), the paan and makhana (lotus seeds) as characteristic foods; and the cultural figures — Gautama (the logician), Kanada (the philosopher), Janaka (the king-sage), Vidyapati, 'Ugna' (the Shiva-as-servant legend), and others.

The Rana ke Baat Bandhu song is a call to martial action ('Ran ke baat bandhu chal sina tani re / Rana ke baat, friends, march with chest thrust forward') that frames national defence in the seasonal imagery of the monsoon: 'Pawan rah saat vyarth jahi ne tufan re / Vyartha o badara... badhi ne har' ('Let not the seven winds go to waste without a storm / Let not the clouds be fruitless... let not the ploughman restrain'). This song connects the patriotic tradition with the agrarian-ecological imagery of Mithila — fighting for the land is fighting for the fields, the rivers, the rains.

## 5.6 Loka-Geet and Nachhari Tradition

The Nachhari songs — unique to the Mithila tradition — are among the most tonally distinctive in the collection. Their comic-devotional register is achieved through a specific technique: presenting Shiva from the perspective of an anxious mother (Maina, Parvati's mother) or an incredulous devotee, cataloguing his unconventional attributes in mock-serious terms. 'Ang ulang charm ta pahiran / Tan me bhasm lagaune / Bhal chandr sang gang jata me / Sarp gala lapataune, ho rama' ('Wearing only hide on his naked body / Smearing ash on his form / With moon and Ganga in his matted hair / Serpent wound around his neck, O Rama'). The repeated 'ho rama' refrain creates a gentle irony: invoking the pious exclamation in the context of Shiva's scandalous appearance.

The Jogira songs (the Holi songs in the voice of a wandering yogi) represent another traditional Maithili folk-song type: the Jogira (from 'jogi' — ascetic/wanderer) tradition uses the figure of the wandering yogi/jogi as a comic-erotic mask, enabling social commentary and erotic play under the license of the Holi festival. Kamal's Geet-Natya (dramatic song-play) on Holi brings this tradition into dialogue with contemporary urban youth experience.

## 5.7 Contemporary Songs: COVID and Social Commentary

The COVID-19 pandemic songs represent Kamal's most topically contemporary writing. The Samajik/Samkalin geet section includes: a satirical song on political response to the pandemic ('Mantri, mukhamantri ke bhashan ghoshna / Shankh dapur yo' — 'Ministers, Chief Ministers' speeches and announcements / The conch and the drum'), criticising empty political rhetoric while people starve; and a contemplative Geetika on the pandemic's enforced isolation ('Jani nikalhu katahu, akaran / Be pasral sagar sankraman' — 'Don't go out anywhere without reason / All around has spread the contagion of disease'). The pandemic songs demonstrate that the traditional Maithili geet form can be

made to carry contemporary social and political content without losing its musical and lyrical character.

## 6. Western Critical Theories Applied to Kamal-Taal

### 6.1 Romantic Lyric Theory

The Western Romantic tradition (Wordsworth, Keats, Shelley, Coleridge) theorised the lyric poem as the spontaneous overflow of powerful feelings, the expression of the poet's own emotional experience in a form that communicates through music-language to produce analogous emotional states in the reader. Wordsworth's famous definition of poetry as 'the spontaneous overflow of powerful feelings: it takes its origin from emotion recollected in tranquillity' is directly applicable to the viraha songs of Kamal-Taal, where the separated wife's longing is both expressed and structured through the formal patterns of the geet.

Keats's concept of 'negative capability' — the capacity to be in uncertainties, mysteries, doubts, without any irritable reaching after fact and reason — finds a parallel in the Maithili geet's characteristic mode of lingering in emotional states without resolving them. The viraha songs do not move toward reunion; they dwell in the anguish of separation as an aesthetic state in itself. This is precisely what Keats meant by negative capability: the lyric capacity to inhabit an emotional state without demanding its resolution.

However, the Western Romantic lyric differs from the Maithili geet in a crucial structural respect: the Romantic lyric is primarily a private, individual, written-for-reading form; the Maithili geet is a social, collective, performance-oriented form. Where Wordsworth's poetry requires solitary reading for full experience, Kamal's songs require collective performance — a puja gathering, a festival community, a diaspora cultural event — for their full social and emotional function.

### 6.2 New Criticism and Close Reading

New Criticism (I.A. Richards, Cleanth Brooks, Robert Penn Warren) emphasised the close reading of the literary text as a self-sufficient verbal artefact, attending to its internal tensions, irony, paradox, and ambiguity.

Applied to Kamal's songs, this approach yields productive insights into the compression and multi-layering of meaning within the geet form.

The devotional song 'Maiya hamar dukha kahiya je sunbai / Agi aji sunbai de kakara se kahbai' ('Mother, when will you hear my sorrows / Come today and hear them, or who else shall I tell?') achieves through simple diction a complex emotional paradox: the devotee asks the goddess 'when will you listen?' — implying that the goddess has not been listening — yet the very act of singing to the goddess enacts the faith that she does listen. This paradox — the faith expressed through the question that doubts the faith — is precisely the kind of ironic tension that New Criticism identified as the mark of literary achievement. It is also, in Navya Nyaya terms, a Tarka (hypothetical counter-argument) within the devotional discourse.

## 6.3 Performance Theory

Richard Schechner's performance theory and J.L. Austin's speech act theory (How to Do Things with Words, 1962) provide complementary frameworks for understanding the Geet as a performative rather than merely descriptive linguistic act. Austin distinguishes between constative speech acts (describing facts) and performative speech acts (doing things through words: 'I promise', 'I hereby declare', etc.). The Geet is fundamentally performative in Austin's sense: singing a vandana (invocation song) does not merely describe devotion but enacts it; singing a sohar (birth-celebration song) does not merely represent joy but constitutes the celebration; singing a Holi song does not merely describe the festival but participates in its performance.

This performative dimension of the Geet is why the songs in Kamal-Taal are not merely poems to be read but scores for community performance events. The Mithila Sanskriti Parishad that publishes them is itself a performance institution — a cultural association whose primary function is the organisation of community performance events at which these songs are sung. The publication of the Geet Sangraha is thus not the endpoint of the songs' life but a preservation/distribution mechanism for the performance tradition.

## 6.4 Feminist Theory and Women's Voice in Kamal's Songs

A significant proportion of Kamal-Taal's songs are written from the perspective of female voices: the devoted wife, the young bride, the mother, the sister, the devotee-woman before the goddess. Feminist literary criticism (Elaine Showalter, Sandra Gilbert and Susan Gubar) asks whose voice speaks in literary texts and whose experience is validated by the literary tradition. In

Kamal's case, the female-voiced songs raise interesting questions: a male poet ventriloquising the female perspective in a traditionally female song genre (the sohar, the vivah geet, the viraha song are all canonically women's oral forms).

This cross-gender literary voice is not unique to Kamal — it is entirely conventional in the Maithili tradition, where male poets (including Vidyapati himself) frequently wrote from female perspectives, particularly in the Radha-Krishna padavali tradition where the gopika's (female devotee's) perspective is the primary lyric mode. In Sanskrit aesthetics, this is theorised as the Nayika-Bhava (female-hero's emotional state) — the capacity of the (typically male) poet to inhabit the female emotional register as the appropriate mode for expressing devotional or romantic Rasa.

A feminist reading might nonetheless point to the limits of this male-authored female voice: the women in Kamal's songs are largely defined by their relationships (wife of the absent husband, daughter of Maina, devotee of the mother-goddess), and their suffering is aestheticised through the viraha Rasa framework rather than socially analysed. The women's subordination within the domestic-ritual economy of Mithila is present in the songs but is rendered as aesthetic and emotional material rather than as social critique.

## 6.5 Postcolonial Theory: Language, Identity, and Diaspora

Kamal's literary project, as situated in the Kolkata Maithili diaspora and published by Mithila Sanskriti Parishad, can be read through the postcolonial lens of diaspora cultural politics. Homi Bhabha's concept of the 'third space' — the cultural space produced between origin and destination, between homeland and host-land — describes precisely the cultural location of the Maithili diaspora in Kolkata. The songs in Kamal-Taal are produced in this third space: they are not the songs of Madhubani village (which Kamal left in his youth) nor the songs of Kolkata Bengali culture (the dominant cultural matrix in which he lives), but the songs of a community that maintains its distinct cultural identity through precisely the kind of cultural production that Kamal-Taal represents.

Frantz Fanon's analysis of colonised cultures and their linguistic politics is relevant to the context of Maithili as a language that was for decades denied official recognition by both the colonial administration and the post-independence Indian state (Maithili was added to the Eighth Schedule only in 2003). The very act of writing, publishing, and distributing Maithili songs through a cultural institution in Kolkata is an act of cultural resistance in Fanon's sense: the assertion of a distinct linguistic-cultural identity against the pressures of assimilation into Hindi and Bengali dominant cultures.

## 7. The Videha Parallel History Framework

Gajendra Thakur's Videha Maithili eJournal (www.videha.co.in, ISSN 2229-547X) and its Parallel History project provides an essential contextual framework for understanding Kamal-Taal. The Videha Archive (videha.co.in/pothi.htm) has preserved and made accessible an enormous corpus of Maithili literary works — from classical texts (Charyyapada, Vidyapati's padavalis, Varna Ratnakar) through the modern period to contemporary writers including Kameshwar Jha 'Kamal'.

The Videha Parallel History framework contests the dominant Maithili literary historiography in several ways relevant to understanding Kamal's songs: First, it asserts the centrality of the oral-folk-musical tradition — the geet, the nach, the kirtan, the sohar — as the primary vehicle of Maithili literary expression, rather than the Sanskrit-influenced written classical tradition that dominant literary histories have privileged. Second, it documents the contributions of non-elite, diaspora, and regional writers who do not receive recognition within institutional literary culture. Third, it asserts the Tirhuta (Mithilakshar) script tradition as equally legitimate to the Devanagari transcription used for most modern Maithili publications, reflecting the pre-modern manuscript culture of Mithila.

Kamal-Taal's publication by Mithila Sanskriti Parishad, Kolkata — a diaspora institution rather than a Bihar-based academic or state institution — positions it within the Videha framework's valorisation of community-based, self-funded, self-organised cultural production outside the institutional literary establishment. The publisher's preface explicitly cites Lochana's Ragatarangini and mentions the disappearing Raga-Bhas tradition — concerns that align precisely with the Videha framework's emphasis on documenting and preserving the full range of Mithila's cultural heritage, including what is threatened with extinction.

The Videha framework also helps contextualise the Azadi ka Amrit Mahotsav framing of Kamal-Taal's publication. The Parallel History project has consistently argued that Mithila's cultural contribution to Indian civilisation has been systematically undervalued in the dominant national narrative — that figures like Gautama, Kanada, Yajnavalkya, Vidyapati, and the entire tradition of Navya Nyaya logic have been appropriated into the Sanskrit classical tradition while their Mithila specificity has been erased. Kamal's Mithila-pride

song 'Jay-Jay Mithila Pawan Dhaam' — naming these figures as Mithila's cultural heritage — is a Parallel History assertion: this is what Mithila has contributed to India's seventy-five years of independence, and before.

## 8. Navya Nyaya Epistemology Applied to Song-Poetry

Navya Nyaya (New Logic), the philosophical school that arose in Mithila with Gaṅgeśa Upadhyaya's Tattvacintamani (c. 1325 CE), offers a distinctive epistemological framework for analysing how song-poetry produces knowledge and valid experience. Applying Navya Nyaya to Kamal's songs is not merely an academic exercise but a culturally grounded interpretive act: these songs emerge from the same Mithila intellectual tradition that produced Gaṅgeśa, Raghunatha Siromani, and the entire Navya Nyaya school.

### 8.1 Pramana in Lyric Cognition

The four Pramanas (sources of valid knowledge) — Pratyaksha (perception), Anumana (inference), Upamana (comparison), and Shabda (testimony) — each operate distinctively in the experience of song. The Pratyaksha of song is the immediate perceptual experience of the musical sound (svara), rhythm (tala), and verbal meaning (artha) as they are performed: the totality of the song as heard in performance. This is a multi-sensory Pratyaksha that cannot be adequately represented in the written text alone — which is why a Geet Sangraha is always a partial representation of the songs' full reality.

Anumana (inferential knowledge) is activated when the listener infers emotional states and situations from the songs' imagery. The viraha song's monsoon imagery ('dark clouds, lightning, flooding fields, the koyal's call') does not literally depict the separated wife's emotional state but enables the listener to infer it through the established cultural Vyapti (invariable concomitance) between monsoon imagery and longing. This inference is not arbitrary but rests on the deeply conventional, culturally established correspondence between seasonal natural phenomena and human emotional states — what Sanskrit aesthetics calls Saadhaarana (generalised/universal) emotional knowledge.

## 8.2 Shabda Pramana and the Oral-Musical Tradition

Navya Nyaya's sophisticated analysis of Shabda Pramana (valid verbal testimony) is directly applicable to the oral transmission of the Geet tradition. In the Navya Nyaya framework, Shabda Pramana is valid when: the speaker (Vakta) is an Apta (reliable, authoritative witness with genuine knowledge), the words are grammatically well-formed (Vyakarana-shuddha), and the context of utterance is appropriate (Yogyata). The oral song tradition transmits knowledge — cultural knowledge, devotional knowledge, seasonal-ecological knowledge — through exactly this mechanism of Shabda Pramana.

The singer of the geet is constituted as Apta by the tradition itself: to sing the sohar at a birth, the vivah geet at a wedding, the vandana at a puja, is to occupy a position of cultural authority guaranteed by the tradition rather than by individual expertise. The song tradition is the collective Apta: the accumulated testimony of generations of singers whose combined authority validates the tradition's content. Kamal, as a composer of new songs in traditional genres, claims this Apta-authority by demonstrating mastery of the genre's formal conventions while bringing his own creative voice within them.

## 8.3 Vyapti and the Logic of Raga

The Navya Nyaya concept of Vyapti (invariable concomitance — the universal rule that underlies valid inference) provides a framework for understanding the Raga system of Indian music. The Raga-Rasa correspondence — the claim that specific Ragas invariably produce specific emotional effects — is a Vyapti claim: 'Where there is Raga Megh Malhar, there is the effect of the monsoon and its associated emotions (longing, fertility, renewal).' The entire system of classical Indian music theory rests on these Vyaptis, established through centuries of empirical musical practice and theorised in texts from the Natyashastra to the Sangita Ratnakara to Lochana's Ragatarangini.

Navya Nyaya's sophisticated handling of exceptions to Vyapti (the Upadhi or limiting condition that restricts the invariable rule) is also relevant: not every performance of Megh Malhar produces the monsoon-longing effect in every listener — the Upadhi conditions include: the listener's cultural formation, the performance context, the singer's skill, and the listener's personal emotional state. This is precisely the position of the Mithila diaspora geet: for the diaspora listener, the monsoon-longing songs produce their full emotional effect only if the listener has the cultural formation to activate the Vyapti. For a listener without this formation, the Vyapti fails — the song remains mere sound.

### 8.4 Gaṅgeśa's Tattvacintamani and the Analysis of Poetic Meaning

Gaṅgeśa's Tattvacintamani (c. 1325 CE) is organised around the analysis of the four Pramanas, with particular attention to the conditions under which verbal testimony (Shabda) produces valid knowledge. His concept of the 'Tatparya' (purport or intended meaning) of an utterance — the totality of meaning that a speaker intends to communicate — is particularly relevant to the multi-layered meaning of the geet.

The Tatparya of a Ganesh Vandana is not merely 'praise of Ganesh' but the full complex of intentions: the performance of devotion, the establishment of an auspicious beginning, the self-constitution of the poet as devotee, the invocation of the deity's grace for the literary work being offered, and the cultural assertion of the Mithila devotional tradition. Gaṅgeśa's analytical framework helps us see that even the simplest-seeming devotional song carries a complex intentional structure that cannot be reduced to its literal semantic content.

The concept of Anuvyavasaya (reflective meta-cognition — the awareness of one's own cognitive states) in Navya Nyaya is relevant to the most philosophically sophisticated songs in Kamal-Taal: the Geetika on COVID isolation ('Jani nikalhu katahu, akaran / Be pasral sagar sankraman') and the philosophical life-song ('Bich kanthe phansala halahala jeenga') both exhibit a quality of Anuvyavasaya — reflection on the conditions and limits of human experience — that transcends the particular social situation to achieve more general philosophical resonance.

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## 9. Detailed Textual Analysis of Selected Songs

### 9.1 Ganesh Vandana (Opening Song)

The first Ganesh Vandana — 'Jay Ganapati Gajawadan Ganesh / Girija nandan tanay Mahesh' — demonstrates several formal characteristics of the Maithili vandana tradition. The epithets are systematically arranged: Gajawadan (elephant-faced), Ganesh (lord of the ganas), Girija-nandan (Parvati's son), Mahesh-tanay (Shiva's son), Vignahara (remover of obstacles), Lambodar (large-bellied), Gananayak (leader of the ganas), Modak-bhog (receiver of

modak offerings), Mushak-savari (mouse-vehicle rider). Each epithet is both a devotional act (naming the deity's attributes) and a mnemonic device (enabling the tradition's transmission through memorable accumulation).

The refrain 'Girija nandan' — 'O son of Girija' — weaves through the stanzas as a structural-musical anchor, providing the Tala (rhythmic) framework around which the changing narrative stanzas are organised. This is the classical refrain (dhruva) structure of the kirtan-pad, as described in medieval music-theoretical texts. The closing stanza's signature: 'Sunahu dayanidhana vinati mora / Sakal Kamal vighn karu dur' — the name 'Kamal' (lotus) appearing as both the poet's name and the devotional symbol — achieves the traditional bhanita (poet's signature) function while simultaneously constituting the poet as a humble suppliant.

## 9.2 The Nachhari: 'Nach Dekhu He Gaura'

The Nachhari 'Nach dekhu he gaura, nach dekhu he / Shiv gelah baurai gaura, nach dekhu he' ('Watch the dance, O Gaura, watch the dance / Shiva has gone mad, O Gaura, watch the dance') is a masterpiece of the genre. Its opening couplet establishes the comic-ironic register immediately: 'Shiva has gone mad' — the cosmic dancer viewed through his wife's bewildered human eyes. The subsequent stanzas accumulate the spectacle of Shiva's ecstatic trance-dance: 'Ganga shish haharay, jhankhi khasala rudra-mal, khuli khasala mrigchhal / Chhi besudh digambar nache behal' ('The Ganga roars on his head, the rudra-mala slips, the deer-hide falls open / The naked sky-clad one dances in ecstasy').

The song's structure moves through three frames of cosmic reference: the physical spectacle of Shiva's dance (Ganga, rudra-mala, the deer-hide), the supernatural accompaniment (ghosts, spirits, the inebriated Nandi dancing), and the cosmic consequence (all three worlds convulsed, Brahma and Vishnu confused). The Nachhari form's genius is the domestication of this cosmic spectacle through Gauri's domestic perspective: she is not a cosmic being witnessing a divine performance but an anxious wife watching her husband's frightening behaviour.

## 9.3 The Viraha Song: 'Biti Gelai Fiyon Mahinma'

The Chaitabar (spring farewell song) 'Biti gelai fiyon mahinma, ho rama, piya beimanma / Elathi kaha hamar sajjanma, ho rama, piya beimanma' ('The month of Phagun has passed, O Rama, my faithless beloved / My beloved did not come, O Rama, my faithless beloved') achieves through extraordinary compression the full emotional structure of the viraha song. The repeated 'ho

rama' — an exclamation of grief that simultaneously invokes the divine witness — and 'piya beimanma' ('faithless beloved') are both emotional release and narrative summary.

Each stanza adds a dimension of loss: 'Phul sabh khili gelai, prakriti sambari gelai' ('All the flowers have bloomed, nature has adorned herself') — spring's beauty makes the absence more acute, not less. 'Baisal pardesiya, piya nirmohiya' ('Sitting in foreign lands, the heartless beloved') — 'pardesiya' (one in a foreign land) is both realistic (the economic migration that separates Mithila husbands from their wives) and metaphysical (the beloved as a stranger to one's heart). 'Pati likhal ne sudhinama, ho rama' ('Did not even write a letter with news of self, O Rama') — in the age of postal correspondence, the absence of the letter is the measure of abandonment.

## 9.4 The COVID Geetika

The COVID-19 Geetika 'Jani nikalhu katahu, akaran / Be pasral sagar sankraman kana-kana' ('Do not go out anywhere without reason / For disease has spread like an ocean, particle by particle') demonstrates the Maithili geet tradition's capacity for contemporary social-moral instruction in the classical sandesha (message) mode. The song moves through social observation ('Dur bhelai manukh, manukhi chhutahar / Mit mani ahi hit swajan-parijan' — 'Human beings have moved apart, touch has become contamination / Those considered friends and dear ones'), calendar disruption ('Sab pawni tihar gam note puchari / Parheye me rakhu evan tan-man' — 'All festivals and home-visits / Keep body and mind in restraint'), and philosophical consolation ('Tam chhatai amawas ke nishchay kamal / Puni aaet ijar chane poonam angan' — 'The darkness of the new moon will definitely clear, Kamal / The full-moon light will return to the courtyard').

The use of the astronomical metaphor for pandemic darkness and recovery — the new moon's darkness (amawas) giving way to the full moon's light (poonam) — is both a classical consolatory trope (the turning of natural cycles as promise of recovery) and a specifically Maithili seasonal image (the full moon's importance in Mithila agricultural-ritual life, particularly Chhath and Sharad Purnima). The poet's name signature 'Kamal' in the penultimate line ('nishchay kamal' — with double meaning: 'definitely, O Kamal' and 'the lotus [will bloom again]') achieves the traditional bhanita function while binding the personal and the social in a single image.

## 10. Thematic Synthesis: Kamal's Vision of Mithila and the World

### *a. Mithila as Sacred Geography*

Across the devotional, mythological, and patriotic songs, Kamal consistently constructs Mithila as a sacred landscape: the birthplace of Sita (Janaki), the homeland of Vidyapati, the meeting point of rivers Koshi and Kamla, the land of paan and makhana, the seat of the Navya Nyaya philosophers and the Dhrupad singers. This sacred geography is both devotional and political: it asserts Mithila's distinct cultural identity against the homogenising pressure of Bihar state identity and the national Hindi mainstream.

### *b. The Eternal Geet as Cultural Survival*

The preface's claim that the Geet is immortal — 'Geetodyan mein patahjhad nahi aaya, nahi aayega' ('In the garden of song, autumn has not come, will not come') — is both aesthetic claim and cultural-political statement. Against the documented disappearance of traditional Raga-Bhas modes, the migration of communities away from the homeland, and the economic pressures that threaten traditional cultural practices, Kamal's songs assert the Geet's capacity to survive and regenerate. This is the deepest function of Kamal-Taal as a cultural artefact.

### *c. The Lotus: Symbol and Signature*

The lotus (kamal) is the multi-valent symbol that unifies the collection: it is the poet's name, the aesthetic ideal of detached beauty rising from muddy waters, the divine symbol (the lotus-seat of Brahma, Lakshmi, Saraswati), and the image of purity in the midst of worldly contingency. The collection's title Kamal-Taal (Lotus-Rhythm/Lotus-Lake) is the most condensed expression of this symbolic complex. Like the lotus, which 'does not absorb the water it floats in' — the classical image of detachment — the songs aspire to an aesthetic purity that transcends the contingent social situations they address.

### *d. Devotion as the Song's Ground*

The placement of the devotional songs at the beginning and the organisation of the collection around the liturgical sequence (Ganesh, Hanuman, Saraswati, Devi, Rama-Sita, Krishna, Shiva) establishes Bhakti (devotion) as the foundational aesthetic-spiritual ground of all the songs, even those addressing social, romantic, or contemporary themes. The Bhakti tradition — from

Vidyapati through the medieval Bhakta poets to the contemporary kirtan tradition — is the unifying cultural-philosophical framework within which Kamal's entire creative project is situated.

### *e. The Living Tradition of Community Performance*

Finally, Kamal-Taal is a record of community performance practice, not merely an individual poet's creation. The songs exist within and for the performance contexts of the Maithili diaspora community in Kolkata: puja celebrations, festival performances, cultural events organised by Mithila Sanskriti Parishad. The collection functions as a repository of community song-culture — a living tradition's archive of itself — as much as an individual literary achievement. This communal dimension is what the Navya Nyaya concept of Shabda Pramana captures: the tradition's collective testimony, validated by the community's long use and recognition.

## 11. Conclusion and Critical Assessment

Kameshwar Jha 'Kamal' and his Kamal-Taal represent something that is easy to overlook in critical discussions of Maithili literature focused on the prestigious genres of novel, drama, and experimental poetry: the living tradition of the Geet (song-poem) as the primary carrier of Maithili cultural memory, community identity, and emotional life. This is not a minor or peripheral tradition — it is, as the preface rightly claims, the oldest, most continuous, most socially embedded dimension of Maithili literary practice, going back at least to Vidyapati and possibly to the Charyyapada.

Kamal's achievement in Kamal-Taal is the demonstration that this ancient tradition is not frozen in a classical past but is alive, flexible, and capable of accommodating new content (COVID, contemporary patriotism, modern romantic experience) within its formal structures (the bhanita signature, the refrain/dhruva structure, the Raga-Rasa correspondences, the devotional hierarchy). This adaptive vitality is the mark of a living literary tradition — and it is achieved not through formal innovation (Kamal is not an experimentalist) but through the deepening and broadening of existing forms.

His most significant limitation — from the perspective of contemporary literary criticism — is perhaps his conservatism in gender representation: the female voices in his songs, though abundant and emotionally rich, remain within the traditional frameworks of wife, devotee, and ritual participant rather than

engaging with the radically changed social positions of Mithila women in the contemporary period. This is, however, less a personal failing than a formal constraint: the traditional song genres he works in carry their gender assumptions as structural features, and innovation in this dimension would require more experimental formal approaches.

Through the multiple critical frameworks applied here — Indian Rasa and Dhvani theory, the Raga-Bhas and Ragatarangini music tradition, the Vidyapati legacy, Western Romantic lyric theory, New Criticism, performance theory, feminist criticism, postcolonial diaspora theory, the Videha Parallel History framework, and Navya Nyaya epistemology — a coherent and significant literary profile emerges: Kameshwar Jha 'Kamal' is a custodian and transmitter of one of Mithila's most ancient and vital cultural traditions, a practitioner of the Geet with genuine lyric skill and formal mastery, and a voice of the Maithili diaspora community whose songs perform the essential cultural work of keeping a community's language, music, devotion, and collective memory alive across geographic displacement.

In the terms of Navya Nyaya's epistemology: his songs are Shabda Pramana — valid verbal testimony — about the living experience of Mithila's culture in the twenty-first century. In the terms of Bharata's Natyashastra: they achieve the Lokasangraha (social holding-together) function that is drama and song's highest purpose. In the terms of Vidyapati's own formulation: they are yet another iteration of the love that 'grows new moment by moment' — the love for the mother tongue, the mother goddess, the motherland, and the human beloved, all singing together in the singular but many-voiced lotus-pond of Kamal-Taal.

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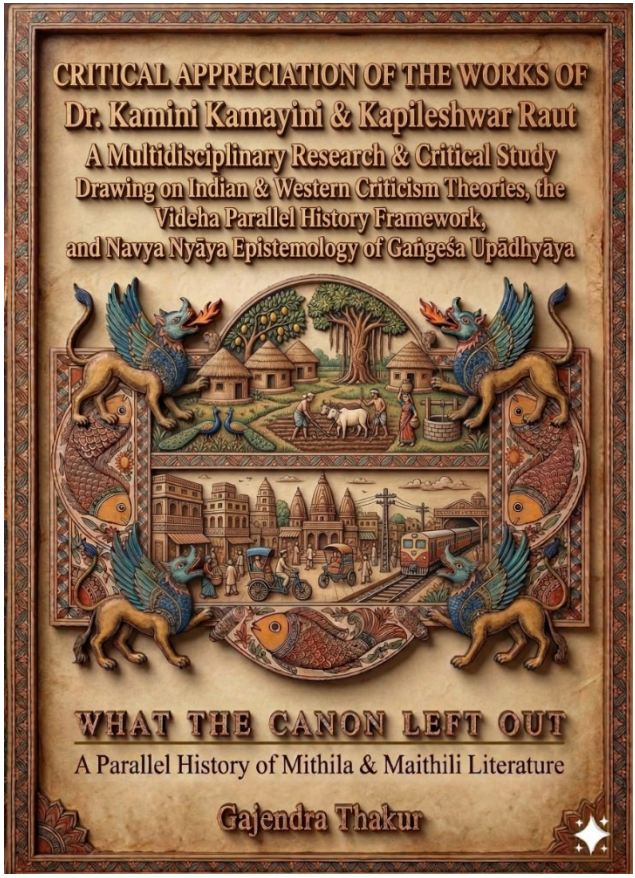
## Online Resources

- Videha Archive of Maithili Literature: www.videha.co.in/pothi.htm
- Mithila Sanskriti Parishad Archive: available through Videha
- Vidyapati Padavali (digital): archive.org/details/maithili_202209/Nagendranath_Gupt_Vidyapati_Padyavali.pdf

**LESSON 036 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**




# CRITICAL APPRECIATION OF THE WORKS OF

**Dr. Kamini Kamayini & Kapileshwar Raut**

*A Multidisciplinary Research & Critical Study*

Drawing on Indian & Western Criticism Theories, the Videha Parallel History Framework,

and Navya Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya

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# I. Preface & Scope of the Study

This research undertakes a comprehensive critical appreciation of two prominent contemporary Maithili writers: Dr. Kamini Kamayini and Kapileshwar Raut. Both have contributed significantly to the modern corpus of Maithili literature, primarily through the Videha e-journal (ISSN 2229-547X, www.videha.co.in), India's first fortnightly Maithili e-journal edited by Gajendra Thakur since 2004.

The critical methodology of this study is deliberately pluralistic and multidisciplinary. It applies classical Indian aesthetics (Rasa, Dhvani, Aucitya), Western theoretical lenses (New Criticism, Structuralism, Postcolonial Studies, Feminist Theory), the Navya Nyāya epistemological system of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya as formulated in the Tattvacintāmaṇi (c. 14th century CE), and the Videha Parallel History Framework — an approach developed within the Videha movement to evaluate literature against the suppressed, non-caste, subaltern histories of Mithila.

The texts are approached with critical respect for their regional specificity. Maithili literature carries a long continuum from Vidyapati (c. 1352–1448) through colonial-era revivals to the present digital renaissance enabled by the Videha platform. Both authors write in and for a tradition that is simultaneously rooted in Mithilā's ancient heritage and urgently contemporary in its social preoccupations.

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# II. Theoretical Framework

Understanding the works of Kamini Kamayini and Kapileshwar Raut demands a multi-pronged critical apparatus. The following frameworks are deployed in this study:

## A. Indian Poetics: Rasa, Dhvani, and Aucitya

The foundational texts of Indian literary criticism — Bharata's Nāṭyaśāstra, Ānandavardhana's Dhvanyāloka, Abhinavagupta's Abhinavabhāratī, and Kṣemendra's Aucityavicāracarcā — furnish the primary Sanskrit aesthetic vocabulary. Rasa theory identifies eight (later nine) primary aesthetic emotions (śṛṅgāra, hāsya, karuṇa, raudra, vīra, bhayānaka, bībhatsa, adbhuta, and śānta) that literature must evoke in the cultivated reader (sahṛdaya). Dhvani (resonance or suggestion) holds that the highest literary meaning is conveyed

not through the stated but through the suggested — the unstated dimension that a work opens up beyond its literal signification. Aucitya (propriety or decorum) governs the selection of words, emotions, characters, and narrative registers appropriate to each generic form and thematic register.

Applied to the vihaṇi kathā genre — Maithili micro-fiction — these concepts demand that we assess how each brief narrative achieves its affective impact through compression, implication, and an economy of means characteristic of dhvani. Raut's stories regularly deploy karuṇa (pathos) and bībhatsa (disgust/social aversion) to anatomize caste hierarchy, agrarian dispossession, and familial rupture. Kamini Kamayini's poetry exploits śṛṅgāra in its vipralambha (separation) modality and karuṇa to render the inner landscape of Maithili women.

## B. Western Criticism: Key Frameworks

Several Western critical traditions illuminate these texts from different angles:

New Criticism (I.A. Richards, Cleanth Brooks, Robert Penn Warren) foregrounds close textual reading — the analysis of irony, ambiguity, paradox, and internal coherence. It resists reducing literary meaning to biography or social context alone. Applied to Raut's 'Ulahan' (the title story), the New Critical approach attends to the ironic reversal at the narrative's close, where a son's gift-giving triggers a paternal rebuke that unmasks the alienation of capitalist modernity within the rural Mithilā household.

Russian Formalism (Viktor Shklovsky, Boris Eikhenbaum) introduced the concept of defamiliarization (ostranenie) — the literary device that makes the familiar strange and hence newly perceptible. Raut's method of narrating poverty and seasonal labor from the inside — through the consciousness of farmers and laborers — creates precisely this effect for urban readers habituated to viewing rural India through a developmental or anthropological lens.

Postcolonial Criticism (Frantz Fanon, Homi Bhabha, Gayatri Spivak, Edward Said) addresses the double marginalization of Maithili literature: first, as a regional language overshadowed by Hindi in the Indian national imaginary; second, as a literature whose subaltern voices (lower-caste farmers, women, rural laborers) have been further silenced within Maithili itself by a historically Brahmin-dominated literary canon. Both Kamini Kamayini and Kapileshwar Raut represent the disruption of this doubly colonial structure.

Feminist Criticism and Gender Studies (Simone de Beauvoir, Elaine Showalter, bell hooks) are particularly relevant to Kamini Kamayini's creative project. Her poetry and prose insist on the interiority, desire, grief, and social critique of the Maithili woman — a subjectivity long objectified in the dominant aesthetic of Mithilā's Vidyapati tradition, where woman figures primarily as object of the male gaze and vessel of srṅgāra.

Marxist and Social Realist Criticism (Georg Lukács, Raymond Williams) address the way both authors represent economic class, agrarian labor, and the violence of social reproduction in rural Bihar. Raut's stories, in particular, engage directly with the material conditions of Mithilā's peasant economy — drought, crop failure, moneylending, landlessness — in ways that invite Lukácsian analysis of the 'typical character in a typical situation.'

## C. Navya Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (fl. c. 1320–1400 CE) was a Mithilā-born philosopher who composed the Tattvacintāmaṇi ('The Jewel of Reflection on Truth'), a foundational text that inaugurated the Navya Nyāya ('New Logic') school of Indian epistemology. The historical significance here is profound: the greatest logician of medieval India came from Mithilā itself, the very geocultural space in which Kamini Kamayini and Kapileshwar Raut write.

Navya Nyāya epistemology posits four primary pramāṇas (sources of valid knowledge): pratyakṣa (perception), anumāna (inference), upamāna (comparison/analogy), and śabda (testimony/verbal evidence). For literary criticism, this schema offers a rigorous analytical vocabulary:

- Pratyakṣa (Perception): What does the text present directly and sensuously to the reader? Raut's stories are thick with the textures of Mithilā's seasonal cycles — the cold of Māgha, the smell of rice threshing, the sound of handpumps. This is literary pratyakṣa at work.
- Anumāna (Inference): What does the text allow us to infer beyond what is stated? The Navya Nyāya framework for inference (which requires a vyāpti, a universal pervasion relationship between hetu/reason and sādhya/conclusion) maps onto the logic of narrative implication and symbolic meaning in literature.
- Upamāna (Comparison): How do the texts deploy analogy and simile? Both authors use comparisons drawn from the natural environment of Mithilā — monsoon, fish, paddy fields, betel vines — as the primary metaphorical register.

- Śabda (Testimony): Literature itself is a form of śabda — the testimony of a speaker whose veridicality the reader must assess. Both authors' claim to represent Mithilā's social experience invites scrutiny through Navya Nyāya's careful analysis of the conditions under which verbal testimony generates valid knowledge.

  The Navya Nyāya concept of viśeṣaṇatā (the relation of qualifier to qualificand) is particularly productive for literary analysis: every narrative event is constituted by a web of relational properties, and identifying the correct viśeṣaṇa (qualifier) — the specific attribute that determines the meaning of an event — parallels the work of close reading. In Raut's story 'Vamś' (Lineage), the qualifier that transforms the meaning of the adoption narrative is not the legal act of adoption itself but the caste calculations that surround it.

  Gaṅgeśa also contributed the crucial epistemological principle of avacchedakatā — the delimiting relation — which specifies how knowledge of an individual is always knowledge under a description. This maps productively onto the postcolonial insight that the Maithili subject in literature is always 'knowledge under a (caste, gender, class) description.' Both Kamini Kamayini and Raut work to disrupt the default avacchedakas — the caste and patriarchal qualifiers — under which the Maithili subject has historically been known.

## D. The Videha Parallel History Framework

The Videha Parallel History Framework (VPHF) is an evaluative approach developed within and around the Videha e-journal movement. It operates on the following principles:

- Literary value must be assessed not only in terms of formal aesthetic qualities but also in terms of whether a work contributes to the recovery and articulation of suppressed histories — the histories of lower-caste communities, women, and non-Brahmin Mithilā.
- The 'parallel stream' in Maithili literature refers to a counter-canonical tradition that exists alongside — but has been systematically marginalized by — the dominant Brahminical literary canon. The Videha journal, from its founding by Gajendra Thakur, has explicitly positioned itself as a platform for this parallel stream.
- Authenticity of representation is judged by proximity to the lived experience of Mithilā's subaltern communities. Writers like Raut (a farmer from Berma village, Madhubani) and contributors like Kamini Kamayini carry an

authority of embodied experience that is itself a form of epistemological validity.

- The VPHF explicitly critiques syndicated pseudo-criticism — the circulation of caste-biased literary judgments that systematically undervalue works by non-Brahmin, Yadav, Musahar, and other marginalized writers in Maithili.

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## III. The Videha E-Journal: Platform, Context, and Literary Movement

Videha: Pratham Maithili Pāksik E-Patrikā (ISSN 2229-547X) was founded by Gajendra Thakur and has been published fortnightly since 2004, with issues appearing on the 1st and 15th of each month at www.videha.co.in. It is the first and most sustained Maithili fortnightly e-journal, having produced over 350 issues at the time of writing. The journal's editorial board includes Dr. Umesh Mandal (co-editor), Ram Vilas Sahu, Nand Vilas Rai, Sandeep Kumar Safi, and Munnaji (Manoj Kumar Karn) as assistant editors.

Videha represents a conscious literary movement as much as a publication. Its explicit mission statement — 'Manushīmiha Samskṛtām' (Human Culture Here) — signals an aspiration to make Maithili literature a living vehicle of humanist values. The journal publishes short stories, poetry, novels (in serialized form), drama, research essays, translations, children's literature, Mithila paintings, audio-visual content, and critical essays. It maintains a multi-script policy — publishing in both Devanagari and Tirhuta (Mithilākṣara) scripts — as part of its commitment to the full cultural heritage of Mithilā.

The Videha Archive (videha.co.in/pothi.htm) provides free access to hundreds of Maithili books — novels, poetry collections, story collections, and critical works — including the primary texts under examination in this study. Both Kapileshwar Raut's Ulhan and the Videha Sadeha 31 (co-edited by Dr. Kamini Kamayini) are available in the archive.

The Videha Sadeha series — of which issue 31 is examined here — represents a special archival edition, collecting selected prose and verse from the journal's first 350 issues. The title 'Sadeha' (literally 'with body/substance') signals the aspiration to give physical, printable form to what was first published digitally. As described by the journal itself, Videha Sadeha 31 is a collection of Maithili prose and verse co-compiled by Dr. Kamini Kamayini and Kumar Manoj Kashyap. Dr. Kamini Kamayini's editorial role in this project situates her as

both a creative practitioner and a shaping institutional force within the Videha movement.

## IV. Dr. Kamini Kamayini: Biographical & Bibliographical Introduction

Dr. Kamini Kamayini is a contemporary Maithili writer, poet, and scholar, active as both a creative contributor and an editorial collaborator within the Videha literary movement. She writes in multiple genres — poetry (padya), short prose including vihaṇi kathā (micro-fiction), and critical essays — and has been a regular presence in Videha's issues across multiple decades of publication.

Her pen name 'Kamayini' carries intertextual weight: it evokes the epic Hindi poem Kāmāyanī (1936) by Jaishankar Prasad, one of the masterworks of Chhāyāvāda (Romantic-Symbolist) Hindi poetry, whose central female figure, Śraddhā, embodies bhakti and creative energy. By adopting a name resonant with this tradition, the author situates herself in dialogue with the broader Indic literary imaginary while writing specifically in and for Maithili.

Her co-editorship of Videha Sadeha 31 with Kumar Manoj Kashyap establishes her institutional authority. The anthology draws on issues 1 through 350 of the journal, curating the most significant prose and verse for archival preservation. This editorial labor — the selection, organization, and preservation of a literary tradition — is itself a critical act of the highest order.

Based on information derived from the Videha journal archives, Dr. Kamini Kamayini's published works include contributions to multiple issues of Videha spanning poetry, short fiction, and critical writing. Issue 31 of Videha specifically featured her in both the prose section (short stories) and the poetry section, where she appears alongside major Maithili poets of the contemporary period including Dr. Shambhu Kumar Singh, Satishchandra Jha, and Subodh Thakur.

Her creative work has also been included in Videha Maithili Seed Stories, the anthology of Maithili micro-fiction (vihaṇi kathā) edited by Gajendra Thakur, placing her among the defining voices of this distinctly Maithili genre.

### Bibliographical Highlights

- Poetry contributions to Videha (Issues 1–350+), including work in Issue 31
- Short fiction (vihaṇi kathā) in multiple Videha issues
- Co-editorship of Videha Sadeha 31 (Maithili Prose and Verse Archive)
- Inclusion in Videha Maithili Seed Stories anthology
- Research and critical essays in Videha

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## V. Critical Appreciation of Dr. Kamini Kamayini's Works

### A. Poetry: Themes, Imagery, and Formal Characteristics

Dr. Kamini Kamayini's poetry inhabits the rich intersection of lyric interiority, social critique, and the specifically Maithili aesthetic tradition. Her verse participates in what might be called the feminization of Maithili rasa — the reorientation of the tradition's dominant srṅgāra (erotic/romantic) aesthetics from the objectifying male gaze of the Vidyapati tradition toward a first-person female subject who speaks her own desire, grief, and resistance.

Thematically, her poetry engages with: the experience of womanhood in Mithilā's patriarchal social fabric; the relationship between language, identity, and home (the recurring trope of maithilī as mother-tongue and matri-bhumi as mother-land); seasonal imagery drawn from Mithilā's agricultural calendar (monsoon, the paddy cycle, the river Kamala); and the tension between tradition and modernity, ritual and reason.

Her formal approach is characteristically Maithili in its musicality — the tradition values a singing quality (geyatā) in verse — but also modern in its willingness to deploy free verse and prose-poem structures that disrupt the expected metric regularity. This formal modernity parallels the thematic restlessness of the content.

#### *Rasa Analysis*

Applying Bharata's Rasa theory: the dominant rasa in Kamini Kamayini's work is karuṇa (pathos/compassion), frequently in combination with śṛṅgāra in its vipralambha (separation) aspect. The lover who is absent in the classical Vidyapati framework is recast in her work: sometimes the absent beloved is a husband who has migrated for labor (the contemporary reality of Mithilā's male

out-migration), sometimes the mother tongue itself, which is 'separated' from its speakers by the pressures of Hindi-medium education.

The adbhuta (wonder) rasa also operates in poems that celebrate the persistence of Mithilā's artistic and cultural traditions — Mithilā painting (Maḍhubanī), the preparation of pān, the agricultural festivals — in the face of modernizing erasure.

### *Dhvani and Suggestion*

The quality most distinctive of Kamini Kamayini's poetic art, from the standpoint of Ānandavardhana's Dhvani theory, is the layering of suggestion beneath the surface statement. A poem that appears to be about a woman waiting for monsoon rain opens into a meditation on longing, fertility, and the politics of women's patience. The stated meaning (vācyārtha) serves as vehicle for an unstated but richly present suggested meaning (vyañjanārtha) — precisely the dhvani effect that Ānandavardhana identified as the soul of great poetry.

### *Feminist Critical Reading*

Elaine Showalter's tripartite model of women's literary history — the 'feminine' phase (imitation of male norms), the 'feminist' phase (protest and advocacy), and the 'female' phase (the search for an authentic women's literary tradition) — illuminates Kamini Kamayini's position. Her work participates in all three phases simultaneously, which is itself a marker of sophisticated feminist literary consciousness: it inhabits and critiques the Maithili tradition simultaneously.

From a Spivakian postcolonial feminist perspective, her writing addresses the question of whether the Maithili woman can 'speak' within the constraints of both Indian nationalism (which marginalizes regional languages) and regional patriarchalism (which marginalizes women within the regional tradition). Her creative output answers this question affirmatively, while acknowledging the difficulty of the position.

## B. Short Prose and Vihaṇi Kathā

Kamini Kamayini's short fiction demonstrates her mastery of the vihaṇi kathā — a genre that is, as the critical literature notes, 'the pure property of Maithili literature' (IJCRT, 2025). The genre demands extreme compression: a complete narrative with character, situation, tension, and resolution must be achieved in a very small space. The craft lies in what is withheld as much as what is stated.

Her stories published in Issue 31 of Videha represent a range of social situations drawn from Mithilā's village life, with particular attention to women's experiences — the pressures of the marital household, the economics of domestic labor, and the small resistances that constitute women's agency in patriarchal settings.

In formal terms, her prose is notable for its dialogue-driven momentum — conversation is the primary engine of narrative revelation — and for its deployment of the Maithili spoken vernacular rather than a Sanskritized literary register. This linguistic choice is itself a political act: it prioritizes accessibility, orality, and community over literary prestige.

## C. Application of Critical Frameworks to Kamini Kamayini

### *Navya Nyāya Reading*

Applying Gaṅgeśa's epistemological framework: Kamini Kamayini's creative work can be read as an extended interrogation of the pramāṇas — the sources of valid knowledge — available to Maithili women within a patriarchal social order. Her poems consistently stage the conflict between pratyakṣa (direct perceptual experience of women's lives) and śabda (the received testimony of tradition, religious authority, and male-authored narrative). The effect is a feminist epistemology: the poem asserts the primacy of direct female experience over inherited textual testimony.

The Navya Nyāya concept of vyāpti (universal pervasion) — the invariable concomitance between a reason and its conclusion — can be applied to her thematic structures. There is an implicit vyāpti in her work: wherever patriarchal constraint is present (hetu), loss of female creative and social agency follows (sādhya). This 'syllogism of oppression' is the deep logical structure of her social critique, and Gaṅgeśa's formal vocabulary gives us precision in naming it.

### *Videha Parallel History Framework*

Within the Videha Parallel History Framework, Kamini Kamayini's work occupies an important position as a female voice in a tradition where the dominant critical apparatus has often been Brahmin and male. Her editorial work on Videha Sadeha 31 extends beyond creative contribution to an act of historical preservation — curating and legitimizing a range of voices, including many from non-dominant communities, for the archival record of Maithili literature.

The VPHF would evaluate her work positively for its consistent attention to the lives of ordinary Mithilā women — not the idealized, classical, decorative femininity of the dominant aesthetic but the laboring, suffering, resisting, desiring women of actual villages.

## VI. Kapileshwar Raut: Biographical & Bibliographical Introduction

Kapileshwar Raut is a Maithili writer from Berma village, Tamuriya sub-district, Madhubani district, Mithilā, Bihar — PIN 847410. He identifies his primary occupation as agriculture (kṛṣi), which is more than a biographical fact: it is the epistemological ground from which his writing proceeds. He is a farmer who writes, and what he writes is shaped entirely by the living experience of farming, rural society, and the economic pressures that constitute Mithilā's agrarian reality.

He is self-presented as a writer who came to Maithili literature through the encouragement of the Videha community — specifically through encounters with Gajendra Thakur, Jagendra Thakur, Jagdash Prasad Mandal, and others associated with the Videha literary movement and its 'Sagar Rāt Dip Jare' (the all-night lamp-burning literary events of Mithilā). His literary development was fostered by the open, non-caste platform of the Videha journal and the Shruti Prakashan publishing house.

His debut story collection, Ulhan (उलहन, 'Reproach/Taunt'), published by Shruti Prakashan, New Delhi, in 2013, contains sixteen vihaṇi kathā (short micro-fictions) in Maithili. The preface (dū śabd, 'two words') is written by Jagdash Prasad Mandal, who identifies Raut as a social realist storyteller whose first story appeared in Videha. Mandal praises Raut's clarity of vision, the social commentary embedded in his stories, and encourages him in his literary journey. The dedication notes express gratitude to Umesh Mandal, Gajendra Thakur, Jagendra Thakur, Kumar Jha, Nitu Kumari, and the Videha community.

Raut's autobiographical note (apn bāt, 'own words') in Ulhan is among the most revealing pieces of the collection. He describes his father's love of Ramayana and harmonium; his own interrupted education (after passing I.A., he could not continue due to family responsibilities following his father's death); caring for elderly grandparents and a widowed mother; managing fields and livestock; and finally coming to writing through the encouragement of the Videha

community. This background of interrupted ambition, rural responsibility, and delayed creative flowering gives his stories their particular emotional credibility.

### Contact and Publication Information

Kapileshwar Raut, Village: Berma, Via: Tamuriya, District: Madhubani, Mithila, Bihar — 847410. Mobile: 9939997757. Publisher: Shruti Prakashan, 1/21, New Rajendra Nagar, New Delhi — 110008. Distributor: Pallavi Distributors, Nirmali (Supaul).

### Works

- Ulhan (उलहन): Vihaṇi Kathā Sangraha (Short Story Collection), Shruti Prakashan, New Delhi, 2013
- Individual stories published in Videha e-journal (issues available at www.videha.co.in)
- Mention in Videha Maithili Seed Stories anthology (Gajendra Thakur, ed.)
- Cited in 'A Critical Analysis of Maithili Short Stories: Twenty-First Century' (IJCRT, 2025) as a significant vihaṇi kathā writer

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## VII. Critical Appreciation of Kapileshwar Raut's Works

### A. Ulhan (उलहन): Overview

Ulhan is a collection of sixteen short narratives written in the vihaṇi kathā (micro-fiction/seed story) genre, published in Devnagari script with Maithili as the language of composition. The title word 'Ulhan' denotes reproach, a taunt, a verbal rebuke — specifically the kind of pointed utterance that exposes a gap between expectation and reality, between what was promised and what was delivered. It is a precisely chosen title: many of the stories turn on exactly this kind of exposé, the moment when someone or something is unmasked through a cutting remark or an ironic reversal.

The collection is dedicated to Raut's village of Berma, and its social geography is entirely Mithilā: the seasonal rhythms of rice and wheat cultivation, the social rituals of birth, marriage, and death, the economics of bāṭāī (sharecropping), the

pressure of moneylending, the human costs of male out-migration, caste hierarchy, the condition of widows, and the question of religious belief and social reform.

The sixteen stories are: 1. Vamś (Lineage), 2. Ulahan (Reproach), 3. Tharharī (The Trembling), 4. Bhog (Enjoyment/Suffering), 5. Kumāri Bhojan (The Maiden's Feast), 6. Kātan Āu Sammelan (Weaving and Conference), 7. Mūdā (However/But), 8. Satamāe (Stepmother), 9. Takrīr (Speech/Sermon), 10. Pān (Betel), 11. Maī Divas (May Day), 12. Bhūkh (Hunger), 13. Bethā (Pain), 14. Kisānk Pūjī (The Farmer's Capital), 15. Chhuā-Chhūt (Untouchability), 16. Kaliyugak Niṇae (The Verdict of Kali Yuga).

## B. Story-by-Story Analysis

### *1. Vamś (Lineage)*

Vamś is the opening story and establishes the collection's central preoccupation with caste ideology. Paraśurām and Kāśalyā, a childless couple ten years into marriage, wish to adopt a child from an orphanage. The wife raises the suggestion hesitantly; her husband is initially open. But her father-in-law Jaduvīr Bābu erupts: 'Crazy! Where is our lineage and where is the orphanage? Whatever caste the child is from — a Musahar or a Muslim — I would have to touch them and make them part of our bloodline.' Kāśalyā's quiet counter-argument — that their own biological sons have abandoned their parents in old age — points to the hollowness of the lineage logic when untethered from actual care and reciprocity. The story ends with Jaduvīr Bābu finally relenting, suggesting the adoption of a child as a Śravaṇ Kumār (the legendary devoted son of Hindu mythology).

Rasa reading: the dominant rasa is the interplay of karuṇa (pathos of childlessness and abandonment) and bībhatsa (the social disgust of caste discrimination), with a resolution that gestures toward adbhuta (wonder at the capacity for change). The New Critical reading emphasizes the ironic reversal: the very tradition that forbids inter-caste adoption (the sanctity of lineage) is deployed by Kāśalyā to argue for adoption — if the goal is to preserve family through devoted care, any loving child qualifies.

### *2. Ulahan (Reproach) — Title Story*

The title story is arguably the collection's central artistic achievement. Jñānacandra returns home from working in Bombay with a suitcase full of gifts — saris, jewelry, toys for children, kurtas, and fifty thousand rupees in cash.

The homecoming is joyous. But later, his young son asks for money to visit the fair, noting that when the family was poor, there was never money for fairs. The father — the narrator's grandfather — tells a story: when he was young, another man would give him chivura (flattened rice) and mangoes, small kindnesses that represented real generosity. The story's moral: the value of a gift is not its monetary size but the sacrifice and love behind it. The son's remark about never having fair-money when they were poor is an unconscious ulahan — a reproach — to the father's years away. The father tells his son never to give such a reproach (ulahan) again.

This story operates on multiple levels simultaneously. As a New Critical close reading reveals, the surface action (a son asking for fair-money) carries a deep subtext (the cost of migration, the love-debt between absent fathers and waiting families, the economics of urban remittance). The grandfather's folktale-within-the-story is the dhvani vehicle through which the unstated meaning — that the years of absence are themselves an ulahan that cannot be repaid by material gifts — is communicated without being stated.

The Navya Nyāya reading: applying the concept of anumāna (inference), the reader infers from the narrative's stated particulars (the gifts, the request for fair-money, the grandfather's story) a universal proposition: wherever wealth replaces presence, emotional debt accumulates. This anumāna depends on a vyāpti established by the narrative — the invariable concomitance of material affluence and relational deficit in the migrant-family nexus.

### *3. Tharharī (The Trembling)*

Set in the bitter cold of Māgha (the coldest month of the North Indian winter), this story presents a powerful contrast between the rich farmer Sureśbābu — wrapped in coat, muffler, and boots — and the laborer Ghuṭar, who has no adequate clothing and copes with winter through hard physical work, wood fires, and improvised bedding. Their conversation about cold, poverty, and survival is both practically informative (Ghuṭar explains his actual strategies for winter survival — making fires from bamboo stalks, sleeping on heated floors, working the body constantly) and philosophically significant. When Sureśbābu asks if Ghuṭar does yoga and pranayama, Ghuṭar's reply is devastating: 'For us, the body's labor is yoga and pranayama.' The story closes with Sureśbābu reflecting that Ghuṭar's observations about class inequality are essentially correct.

The Marxist/social realist reading is prominent here: the story stages the class contradiction between landlord and laborer with sharp economy. Lukács's

concept of the 'typical character in a typical situation' applies: Ghuṭar represents the general condition of Mithilā's agricultural laborers, and Sureśbābu represents the comfortable landowner class whose wealth derives from that labor but whose habits of thought prevent full recognition of the laborers' humanity.

### *4. Bhog (Enjoyment/Suffering)*

Bhog narrates the decline and death of the old patriarch Sānāi, who has lived through family tragedy (the death of multiple grandchildren and family members) and now suffers from a disease that no medicine can touch. A visitor, Ghanaśyām, brings sweets as a gift; Sānāi refuses them, saying that when his son Karaṇa was alive, he never brought such things, and now that he is alone, what use are sweets? The old man's sudden surge of energy — rising to distribute the sweets to his grandchildren and grandnephew — in the face of near-death is the story's emotional climax, captured in an image of a lamp that flares brightly just before it goes out. The story ends with Ghanaśyām wordlessly watching.

The rasa reading: karuṇa dominates, but the concluding image — the flaring lamp — carries both adbhuta and a hint of vīra (heroic pathos). The dhvani is the unstated recognition that love for the living motivates the dying more than any medicine.

### *5. Kumāri Bhojan (The Maiden's Feast)*

This is one of the collection's most philosophically ambitious stories. The young Sañjay challenges his grandmother Siyāvatī on the logic of the Kumāri Bhojan ritual (the ritual feeding of young girls as a religious act): why, he asks, are the girls of our own household excluded from the religious feast that 'kumāris' (maidens) are supposed to receive? If a maiden is sacred, isn't Dolikā (the household's young girl) a maiden too? He extends the critique to the mythological basis of Durgā worship, arguing that the goddess's power is the power of organized collective resistance to tyranny, not the product of individual ritual piety.

The story represents the collection's most sustained engagement with religious critique and rationalism. The grandmother is not presented as a villain but as a person entrapped by the inherited logic of ritual practice. Sañjay's critique is gentle but persistent. The resolution is open: Siyāvatī admits that she will 'think carefully before acting' in future — a small but significant shift.

The Navya Nyāya reading: Sañjay's argument has the structure of a Navya Nyāya anumāna. The hetu (reason): Dolikā is a kumāri. The sādhya (conclusion to be established): Dolikā should receive kumāri bhojan. The vyāpti (universal pervasion): wherever there is a kumāri, there should be the ritual of kumāri bhojan. The story's narrative logic thus replicates the structure of formal Indian philosophical argumentation.

### *6. Kātan Āu Sammelan (Weaving and Conference)*

One of the collection's most complex stories, set around a religious conference organized by the newly elected village headman (mukhiyā) Iśvām. The conference attempts to reconcile Hindu and Muslim religious traditions. A speaker argues that all religions — Islam, Hinduism, Sikhism — are paths to the same truth. But the conference is disrupted by a caste-based crisis: a woman's body arrives during the event, and the question of whether she should be buried according to Hindu or Muslim rites opens a social wound about the woman's history of exploitation by a prominent lawyer. The story thus moves from interfaith harmony to an exposure of how caste and gender violence undercut the conference's high-minded universalism.

### *7. Takrīr (The Sermon)*

In this story, Kājūm participates in a Muslim religious assembly (jamāt) and hears a series of sermons about fasting, proper conduct, and gender relations. One sermon argues that women should always be subordinate to men. The story follows Kājūm home, where he discovers that his advice-giving has not improved his own household: his family has eaten the rice and pulse he was hoarding for the assembly's feast. The irony is sharp: the sermonizer on domestic virtue finds that his own domestic economy has collapsed in his absence.

### *10. Pān (Betel)*

One of the collection's most extended and lyrical stories, Pān traces the pān (betel vine) cultivation of Rāmavtār through the seasons, exploring the elaborate technical knowledge, seasonal vulnerability, and cultural significance of pān farming in Mithilā. The story includes an extended conversation on the history, medicinal properties (vitamins, minerals, anti-bacterial agents), and cultural uses of pān. The story closes with the observation that as young men leave for cities and the old farmers age, the knowledge and practice of pān cultivation is being lost — a pointed ecological and cultural elegy.

### *11. Maī Divas (May Day)*

This story, the collection's most politically explicit, is set on May Day and follows a communist organizer. A labor activist's death during a land dispute becomes the occasion for a social gathering that blurs the lines between progressive politics, religious ritual, and community caste dynamics. The activist had organized across caste lines but died in ambiguous circumstances; the story explores the gap between political rhetoric and social practice.

### *15. Chhuā-Chhūt (Untouchability)*

The shortest and perhaps most compressed story in the collection, this micro-narrative is set during the Durgā Pūjā festival. A Dalit man tries to enter the temple and is stopped by the priest. Separately, at a tea-stall, a Dalit customer is refused service. The man's pointed challenge to the stall-owner — 'If you wash dishes to purify them after other people use them, why don't you wash mine after I use them, and serve me?' — is unanswerable. The story ends with the narrator lost in thought, unable to resolve the contradiction.

### *16. Kaliyugak Niṇae (The Verdict of Kali Yuga)*

The collection's final story is its most mythologically ambitious. Kali Yuga (the present degenerate age of Hindu cosmology) prepares to take over from Dvāpara Yuga. The gods of all three preceding ages come to Kali Yuga. Kali Yuga declares that unlike its predecessors — who required elaborate heavenly administration — it will deliver justice immediately: 'As you act, so shall you receive your fruit immediately, in this life.' The gods are startled and impressed. The story is a compressed moral fable that endorses karmic immediacy and implicitly critiques the deferral of justice to future lives — a subtle critique of conservative religious quietism.

## C. Social Realism and the Mithilā Experience

Across all sixteen stories, Raut demonstrates what Lukács called the 'totality of social relations' — the way in which individual human situations are shaped by and in turn shape the broader economic, caste, and gender structures of their society. No story in Ulhan exists in a social vacuum; every narrative is precisely situated in the material conditions of Mithilā's agrarian economy.

The recurring social preoccupations of the collection include: male out-migration and its effects on families and farming; caste hierarchy and the violence of untouchability; the economics of sharecropping (bāṭāī) and the farmer's capital (pūjī — seed grain, which is a form of capital that, when

consumed, destroys the reproductive capacity of the farm); widow poverty and dependency; religious ritual and its social contradictions; and the slow erosion of traditional agricultural knowledge as younger generations leave.

Raut's language is a significant political choice. He writes in the spoken Maithili of the villages of Madhubani district — phonologically and lexically close to what people actually say — rather than in a Sanskritized or 'high' literary Maithili. This linguistic populism is itself a statement about whose lives and voices are worth literary representation.

## D. Application of Critical Frameworks to Kapileshwar Raut

### *New Critical Reading*

From the New Critical standpoint, Raut's best stories achieve a fine balance between dramatic compression and emotional resonance. The title story 'Ulahan' is a textbook example of the kind of ironic layering Brooks and Warren identified as definitive of poetic excellence — here transposed to micro-fiction. The surface narrative (gift-giving) carries a subterranean emotional charge (the cost of absence) that the narrative's concluding ulahan releases without fully exhausting.

### *Postcolonial Reading*

Raut's writing represents the 'writing back' of a doubly marginalized subject: a lower-caste, rural farmer-writer, writing in a minority regional language, about the lives of people whose social existence is defined by exclusion. His work does not idealize this existence; it represents it with unflinching realism, while insisting on the full humanity of its subjects.

### *Navya Nyāya Reading*

The Navya Nyāya framework, applied to Raut's collection, illuminates the epistemological structure of his narratives. Each story demonstrates what Gaṅgeśa called the pratyakṣa (perceptual directness) that comes from embodied, lived knowledge. Raut knows the weight of harvested grain, the technique of pān cultivation, the social choreography of a village funeral, and the precise temperatures of Māgha cold — and this perceptual precision gives his narratives the authority of testimony (śabda) grounded in direct experience.

The Navya Nyāya concept of avacchedakatā (the delimiting qualifier) is particularly productive for analyzing Raut's social critique. In each story, the narrative labor consists precisely in identifying the correct avacchedaka — the

qualifying condition — that determines the meaning of a situation. In 'Vamś,' the relevant qualifier is not the legal category of 'orphan child' but the caste category that the father-in-law applies. The story's ironic power comes from demonstrating that the patriarch's qualifying frame (caste) is an epistemologically defective avacchedaka — it fails to identify the relevant property (care and devotion) that should determine the choice of heir.

### *Videha Parallel History Framework*

Within the Videha Parallel History Framework, Kapileshwar Raut occupies a paradigmatic position. He is precisely the kind of writer the Videha movement was designed to foster and present: a farmer, from a rural Madhubani village, writing in the spoken vernacular of his community, with direct epistemological authority over the social world he represents. His work is unmediated by the class and caste interests that have historically shaped the Maithili literary canon.

The VPHF's criterion of authenticity of representation is fully met by Raut. His stories are not about rural Mithilā as observed from the outside but as lived from the inside — a crucial distinction that the VPHF values as a marker of genuine literary contribution to the subaltern counter-canon.

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## VIII. Comparative Analysis: Kamini Kamayini and Kapileshwar Raut

Though working in different primary genres — Kamini Kamayini primarily in poetry and editorial scholarship, Raut primarily in micro-fiction — both authors share a fundamental commitment to the representation of Mithilā's social reality from positions of insider knowledge and critical consciousness.

### *Shared Preoccupations*

- Both writers foreground the lives of ordinary Maithili people — women, farmers, laborers — rather than the educated elite.
- Both engage with the contradiction between religious tradition and social justice — the gap between ritual piety and actual humanity.
- Both use the Maithili spoken vernacular rather than a Sanskritized literary register.
- Both are platform writers — they write for and within the Videha movement, which provides both their publication context and their critical community.

- Both address caste hierarchy, though from different angles: Kamini Kamayini through the lens of gender, Raut through the lens of class and caste economy.

***Differences of Approach and Emphasis***

- Kamini Kamayini's work is more lyrical, interior, and subjective; Raut's is more externally social, dialogic, and realist.
- Kamini Kamayini's editorial and critical role in Videha gives her a shaping institutional presence; Raut's contribution is primarily creative.
- Raut's stories are anchored in specific agricultural and seasonal knowledge; Kamini Kamayini's poetry more often moves in the realm of emotional and social abstraction.
- Gender is the organizing analytical category for Kamini Kamayini's work; class and caste are primary for Raut, though gender also features in stories like 'Satamāe' and 'Kumāri Bhojan.'

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## IX. The Navya Nyāya Lens: Epistemological Reading of Both Authors

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya lived and wrote in Mithilā — the same geocultural space that Kamini Kamayini and Kapileshwar Raut inhabit. This is not an incidental coincidence: the Navya Nyāya tradition that Gaṅgeśa established was itself a product of the intellectual culture of Mithilā's paṇḍit community, centered in Darbhanga, Madhubani, and Sitamarhi. The Tattvacintāmaṇi was composed in the same region where Raut's village of Berma is located.

The application of Navya Nyāya to these texts is thus not merely a methodological import from elsewhere — it is a homecoming of sorts, an application of Mithilā's own intellectual tradition to its contemporary literature.

The four pramāṇas of Navya Nyāya — pratyakṣa, anumāna, upamāna, and śabda — function as follows when applied to the literary works:

- Pratyakṣa (Perception): Both authors ground their work in sensory experience. Raut's descriptions of the trembling cold of Māgha, the smell of drying pān leaves, and the sounds of a handpump at dawn constitute literary pratyakṣa. Kamini Kamayini's evocation of monsoon monsoon rains and seasonal transitions similarly invokes perceptual immediacy. The literary

criterion here is vivid particularity — the test of whether the writing truly transmits sensory experience.

- Anumāna (Inference): Both authors construct narratives whose stated events support inferences about unstated social truths. In Raut's 'Ulahan,' the inference from the son's casual request (for fair-money) to the deep structure of father-son alienation is a literary anumāna. The validity of this inference depends on the vyāpti — the universal proposition — that the text has implicitly established: wherever long absence replaces presence, emotional currency is depleted.
- Upamāna (Comparison/Analogy): Raut regularly employs Mithilā-specific analogies. The comparison of a dying man to a lamp that flares before extinction (in 'Bhog') is an upamāna that functions both as aesthetic image and as a conceptual claim about the nature of vital energy. Kamini Kamayini's poetry is rich with analogies drawn from agricultural and natural cycles.
- Śabda (Testimony): Both authors position their work as literary testimony about Mithilā's social reality. The question of testimonial validity — whether the author has the right kind of knowledge to testify to these realities — is answered by their biographical positions: Raut's authority comes from his embodied life as a farmer, Kamini Kamayini's from her embodied experience as a Maithili woman.

The Navya Nyāya concept of anuvyavasāya (apperception — cognition of one's own cognition) is the closest Indian classical analogue to what Western criticism calls reflexivity or metafiction. Neither author is primarily reflexive, but moments of narrative self-consciousness — particularly in the closing lines of stories like 'Ulahan' and 'Chhuā-Chhūt,' where the narrative voice turns to wonder or confusion — represent literary anuvyavasāya: the text cognizing its own limits.

## X. The Videha Parallel History Framework in Practice

The Videha Parallel History Framework (VPHF) assesses literary value in relation to the suppressed counter-histories of Mithilā's non-dominant communities. Applied to Kamini Kamayini and Kapileshwar Raut, the framework yields the following evaluations:

### *Kamini Kamayini through the VPHF*

Her editorial work on Videha Sadeha 31 represents an act of counter-canonical archive-building: the deliberate preservation and amplification of voices — including many non-Brahmin, non-elite writers — that the dominant Maithili literary establishment has systematically undervalued or ignored. The choice of which voices to preserve is itself a political and aesthetic act with lasting consequences for the literary record.

Her creative work's consistent attention to women's interiority and social constraint contributes to the counter-history of Maithili women's experience — a history that has been objectified and aestheticized by the dominant tradition (where woman is object of sṛṅgāra) but rarely given the status of subject with her own perspective.

The VPHF would place Kamini Kamayini in the lineage of what might be called the 'feminist wing of the Videha movement' — writers and editors who use the platform to assert women's full literary subjectivity.

### *Kapileshwar Raut through the VPHF*

Raut's case is paradigmatic for the VPHF. He is precisely the kind of writer the Videha counter-canon was designed to support and validate: a non-elite, non-Brahmin, rural, agricultural writer who has been enabled to publish and be read through the open platform of the Videha e-journal and Shruti Prakashan. Without this platform, his work would likely have remained unpublished and unread.

His stories directly address the suppressed economic and caste histories that the VPHF seeks to recover: the history of sharecroppers, agricultural laborers, untouchables, widows, and the economically dispossessed of Mithilā's villages. This is the 'parallel history' that exists alongside — and is produced by — the landed, Brahmin, traditionally literate culture that has dominated Maithili literary history.

The VPHF would give Raut's work the highest possible evaluation on its criterion of authenticity of representation: he writes what he has lived, and what he has lived is precisely what the dominant tradition has silenced.

## XI. Conclusion

This study has attempted a comprehensive critical appreciation of the works of Dr. Kamini Kamayini and Kapileshwar Raut — two distinct but complementary voices in the contemporary Maithili literary renaissance enabled by the Videha movement. Through the application of Indian classical aesthetics (Rasa, Dhvani, Aucitya), Western critical theories (New Criticism, Russian Formalism, Postcolonial and Feminist Criticism, Marxist Social Realism), the Navya Nyāya epistemological framework of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya, and the Videha Parallel History Framework, the study has sought to demonstrate that both authors make significant and distinctive contributions to the living body of Maithili literature.

Kamini Kamayini's importance is dual: as a creative practitioner who brings women's interiority and social critique to Maithili poetry and prose, and as an institutional force who, through her editorial work on Videha Sadeha 31, actively shapes the archival record of the Maithili literary tradition. Her work represents the feminist wing of the Videha movement's counter-canonical project.

Kapileshwar Raut's Ulhan stands as a significant achievement in the vihaṇi kathā genre — a genre that is itself among the most distinctively Maithili of literary forms. His sixteen stories, grounded in the material and social experience of Mithilā's farming communities, constitute a social chronicle of remarkable precision and humanity. His epistemological authority — the authority of direct perceptual experience — is precisely the authority that the Navya Nyāya tradition would recognize as the most fundamental source of valid knowledge: pratyakṣa, the ground of direct experience.

Both authors, read through the Navya Nyāya lens that Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya forged in the very region they inhabit, demonstrate the profound continuity between Mithilā's oldest philosophical traditions and its newest literary expressions. The fourteenth-century logician who asked how we know what we know, and the twenty-first century storyteller who shows us what his village knows from the inside, are separated by seven centuries but united by the same epistemological ground: the authority of what is directly seen, heard, and experienced.

The Videha Parallel History Framework's final verdict on both writers is unambiguous: they belong to the counter-canon that is now, through the labors of the Videha movement, becoming the canon — the authentic literary record of

Mithilā's full social complexity, not the partial, caste-filtered, and gender-restricted record of the dominant tradition.

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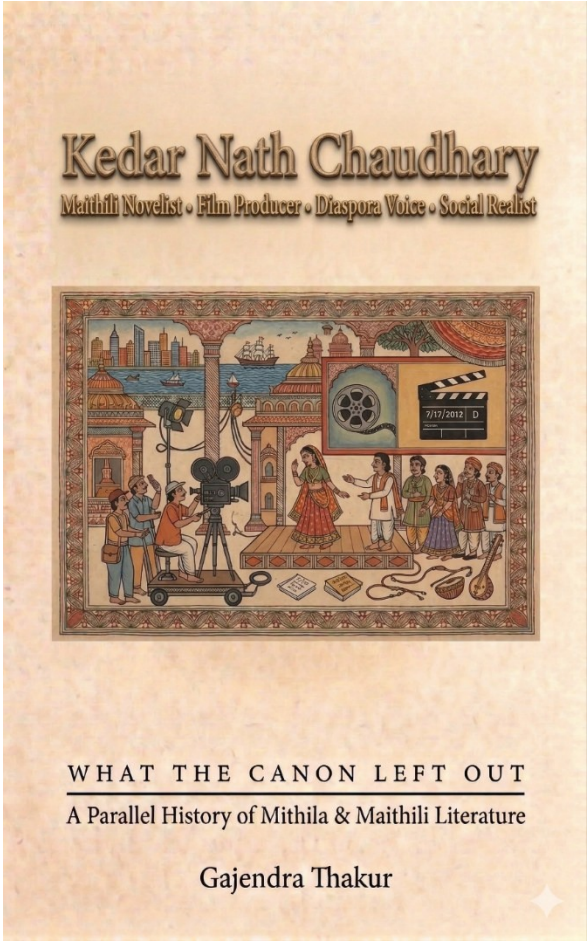
**LESSON 037 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**




# Kedar Nath Chaudhary

Maithili Novelist · Film Producer · Diaspora Voice · Social Realist

*Novels: Chameli Rani · Karar · Mahur · Abara Nahitan · Hina · Ayna*

| | |
|---|---|
| **Born** | 3 January 1936, Nehra, Darbhanga, Bihar |
| **Residence** | Laheriasaray, Darbhanga (since 2000); earlier USA, Iran, Mumbai, Pune |
| **Education** | M.A. Economics (1958); LLB (1959); M.A. Economics, Univ. of California (1969); MBA, Golden Gate Univ., San Francisco (1971) |
| **Maithili Film** | Co-producer, Mamta Gaaye Geet — first Maithili feature film |
| **Novels** | 6 novels: 2004–2018 |
| **Awards** | Videha Sahitya Samman (2013); Prabodh Sahitya Samman (2016); Kedar Samman (2016) for Abara Nahitan |
| **Primary Source** | Videha Issue 352 (Kedar Nath Chaudhary Visheshank), 15 Aug 2022, ISSN 2229-547X |

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## 1. Biographical Profile

Kedar Nath Chaudhary was born on 3 January 1936 in the village of Nehra, Darbhanga District, Bihar. His mother was the late Kusumpari Devi and his father the late Kishori Chaudhary. He completed his schooling in Mithila, then pursued a remarkably cosmopolitan education: an M.A. in Economics from a Bihar university in 1958, an LLB in 1959, followed by a second M.A. in Economics from the University of California in 1969, and an MBA in Marketing and Distribution from Golden Gate University, San Francisco, in 1971. He returned to India in 1978 and spent years in Tehran (Iran) and Frankfurt before settling in Bombay and then Pune. After retirement, he returned permanently in 2000 to Laheriasaray, Darbhanga, where he devoted himself entirely to literary work.

His first wife was the late Kumud Chaudhary; his two daughters are Kiran Jha and Archana Chaudhary. His daughter Archana writes movingly in the Videha

special issue about a father whose silence was a form of depth: 'He never praised us, never scolded us. When he looked at us we understood everything.'

Chaudhary's life trajectory — from a Mithila village to California to Tehran to Frankfurt to Mumbai, and finally back to Darbhanga — is not incidental background. It is the experiential reservoir from which all six of his novels draw. The diaspora experience, the encounter with modernity and capitalism at their most concentrated, the alienation of the educated Indian in a globalised world, and the return to roots that carries both nostalgia and the shock of recognition: these constitute his thematic universe.

## 2. Published Novels: An Annotated Overview

Kedar Nath Chaudhary published six novels in Maithili between 2004 and 2018, all after his return to Darbhanga at the age of sixty-four. This late flowering — beginning creative writing in one's late sixties — is itself significant: it places him outside the mainstream Maithili literary establishment, which had formed its canons and careers decades earlier. The Videha special issue (Issue 352, August 2022) positions this belatedness as both a liability (institutional neglect) and an asset (freedom from orthodoxy).

| Year | Title (Maithili) | Theme / Note |
|---|---|---|
| 2004 | **Chameli Rani** | The first novel; introduces his signature narrative mode of female interiority. A woman negotiates love, social expectation, and personal dignity in post-Partition Mithila. |
| 2006 | **Karar** | Meaning 'agreement' or 'compact'; explores contractual relationships — legal, emotional, marital — in a modernising Mithila. Reviewed by Dr. Kailash Kumar Mishra as a socially incisive work. |
| 2008 | **Mahur** | Meaning 'poison'; the darkest novel in the sequence. Explores the corrosive effects of money, urban migration, and broken kinship on Maithili family structures. |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 2012 | **Abara Nahitan** | The most celebrated novel; 'Abara' (wanderer) and 'Nahitan' (not-wanderer) suggests the dialectic between rootedness and displacement. Winner of Kedar Samman (2016). Extensively critiqued in Videha 352. |
| 2013 | **Hina** | A love narrative exploring Advaita (non-dual) dimensions of romantic attachment. Named for the female protagonist; described by critic Abha Jha as 'an extraordinary account of love's non-duality.' |
| 2018 | **Ayna** | Meaning 'mirror'; a novel read by Hitnath Jha as a chronicle of declining civilisation and culture, functioning as 'the mirror of civilisation's decay.' |

## 2.1 Abara Nahitan: The Pivotal Text

Of the six novels, Abara Nahitan (2012) has attracted by far the most sustained critical attention. Its title enacts a philosophical tension: the wanderer (abara, cognate with Urdu/Hindi awara) set against the negated wanderer (nahitan = nahi + tan, 'not the body' or 'not-wandering'). This duality of rootlessness and belonging maps directly onto Chaudhary's own biography as a returned diaspora writer.

The novel's narrative involves a male protagonist whose life of migration and intellectual displacement brings him into encounter with women who represent different possibilities of Maithili womanhood, community memory, and the meaning of home. Multiple critics in the Videha special issue engage it on different registers: Ajit Kumar Jha reads it as 'an unmatched work'; Laxman Jha Sagar calls it an affirmation of non-wandering rather than wandering ('Abara nahi…tan!'); Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil' praises its 'magnetic writing'; and Pradeep Bihari excavates the secondary female characters as bearers of the novel's most acute social insight.

## 2.2 The Question of Marginalisation

The Videha editor Gajendra Thakur's editorial and his essay 'Kedar Nath Chaudhary — Hunak aa Hunak Upanyas Kar Punapath' both address a central

paradox: despite writing six novels of considerable quality, Chaudhary remained almost entirely unknown outside Mithila's small Maithili literary circuit. Deepak Manjul calls him 'the Kabir of Maithili literature' — meaning the outsider whose truth-telling the establishment cannot easily assimilate. Ashish Anchinhar goes further, proposing the concept of a 'Kedar Nath Yug' (Kedar Nath Era) in Maithili fiction, arguing that his novels collectively opened a new phase characterised by global reference, psychological depth, and willingness to address difficult social realities.

## 3. The Maithili Film Connection

Before his emergence as a novelist, Kedar Nath Chaudhary's most publicly known contribution to Maithili culture was his role as co-producer of Mamta Gaaye Geet — the first Maithili feature film. The other original producer was Madan Mohan Das; the third co-producer was Uday Bhanu Singh, who joined when financial difficulties threatened the project.

The film's complicated production history — conceived, abandoned for approximately eighteen years due to financial failure, and finally rescued by Chaudhary himself (who obtained the rights from Madan Mohan Das and completed its release) — gives it a quality of collective Maithili aspiration deferred and then realised. The lyricist for the film was Ravindra Nath Thakur. Chaudhary's connection to the film is not incidental to reading his fiction: the film project represents the same drive to give Mithila a representational presence in forms (cinema, prose narrative) that the community had historically lacked.

4. Indian Critical Frameworks

Chaudhary's novels invite analysis through multiple traditions of Indian literary criticism, from the classical Sanskrit theories of rasa and dhvani to modern schools of progressive, dalit-subaltern, and feminist criticism. The following sections apply each framework systematically.

### 4.1 Rasa Theory (Bharata Muni's Natyashastra)

The foundational theory of Indian aesthetics, articulated in Bharata Muni's Natyashastra (2nd century BCE to 2nd century CE), holds that literary experience is organised around the evocation of rasas — emotional essences distilled from bhavas (transient emotional states). The nine classical rasas are: shringara (love/beauty), hasya (comedy), karuna (compassion/sorrow), raudra (fury), vira (heroism), bhayanaka (terror), bibhatsa (disgust), adbhuta (wonder), and shanta (peace).

Chaudhary's dominant rasa is undoubtedly karuna — the sorrowful compassion evoked by witnessing lives disrupted by modernity, migration, and institutional failure. In Mahur, the karuna of family dissolution is so pervasive that the novel operates as a sustained elegy for Maithili kinship structures. Abara Nahitan distributes karuna and shringara in counterpoint: the male protagonist's wanderings carry the bhayanaka of rootlessness, while his encounters with

women invoke shringara, frequently shadowed by viraha (the shringara of separation). Hina is perhaps Chaudhary's purest exercise in the shringara rasa, with its Advaita framework transforming romantic love into something approximating the rasa of shanta in its resolution.

The concept of sthayibhava (permanent emotion underlying the transient bhavas) is useful here. Chaudhary's sthayibhava across all six novels is a form of viveka-informed grief — the sorrow of someone who sees clearly, who has experienced enough of the world to understand what is being lost, but who does not sentimentalise that loss. This approximates the rasa of shanta as interpreted by Abhinavagupta in his Abhinavabharati: the peace of disillusionment that transcends rather than evades experience.

| Theory / Framework | Tradition | Application to Chaudhary |
|---|---|---|
| **Rasa Theory** | Bharata, Abhinavagupta (Natyashastra, Abhinavabharati) | Dominant rasa: karuna and shringara in counterpoint. Sthayibhava of viveka-shoka (clear-sighted grief) runs across all six novels. Abara Nahitan achieves shanta rasa through the protagonist's homecoming. |

## 4.2 Dhvani and Vakrokti

Anandavardhana's Dhvanyaloka (9th century CE) proposes that the highest form of poetic meaning operates through dhvani (resonance, suggestion) — what is evoked beyond what is stated. Kuntaka's Vakroktijivita (10th century CE) emphasises vakrokti (oblique expression) as the life-principle of literature. Both theories are directly applicable to Chaudhary's prose style.

Chaudhary's narrative technique is characterised by what might be called productive ellipsis: he consistently omits the explanatory or emotional commentary that lesser fiction provides, leaving the resonance to carry meaning. In Ayna, the mirror metaphor works precisely as dhvani: the 'mirror' is

never decoded symbolically within the text itself; it accumulates meaning through juxtaposition and suggestion. In Chameli Rani, the protagonist's choices are narrated with a flatness of tone that functions as vakrokti — the deflected surface concealing depths of anguish.

The critics in Videha 352 intuitively register this quality. Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil' uses the term 'chumbakiya lekhak' (magnetic writing) for Abara Nahitan — a formulation that captures dhvani precisely: the writing attracts without explaining its pull. Hitnath Jha's reading of Ayna as a 'mirror' of civilisational decay draws on the novel's core dhvani without naming the theoretical category.

| Theory / Framework | Tradition | Application to Chaudhary |
|---|---|---|
| **Dhvani / Vakrokti** | Anandavardhana (Dhvanyaloka); Kuntaka (Vakroktijivita) | Chaudhary's elliptical, oblique style withholds emotional commentary, allowing meaning to resonate through suggestion. Ayna's mirror motif is a sustained dhvani; Chameli Rani's flat narration is vakrokti in prose. |

## 4.3 Auchitya (Propriety / Contextual Decorum)

Kshemendra's Auchityavichara (11th century CE) theorises auchitya — the principle of contextual appropriateness — as the cardinal virtue of literary composition. Every element of a work must be suited to its context: character to situation, language to character, sentiment to narrative moment.

Chaudhary's handling of Maithili language itself demonstrates acute auchitya. He writes a Maithili that is simultaneously rooted in the Mithila spoken vernacular and inflected by the English, Urdu, and American-English vocabulary that his diaspora characters carry. The critic Kameshwar Chaudhary, in his Videha 352 essay, notes that English-educated people can save Maithili — a provocative claim that Chaudhary's novels embody: the

diaspora intellectual's Maithili is different in texture from the village writer's, but it is not less authentic. Its appropriateness lies precisely in its hybridity.

| Theory / Framework | Tradition | Application to Chaudhary |
|---|---|---|
| **Auchitya** | Kshemendra (Auchityavichara) | Chaudhary's hybrid Maithili — combining vernacular roots with diaspora-inflected vocabulary — demonstrates contextual propriety. Each novel calibrates linguistic register to character and situation. |

## 4.4 Navarasa and Maithili Padavali Tradition

Chaudhary's literary formation occurred within a Mithila cultural world shaped by the padavali tradition of Vidyapati — a tradition in which shringara and karuna are intertwined, and in which the experience of viraha (love's separation) is elevated to near-metaphysical status. This formation is evident in the lyrical passages of Hina, where the love narrative draws on the rasika aesthetics of bhakti-shringara even as it inhabits a secular, contemporary context.

Deepak Manjul's characterisation of Chaudhary as 'the Kabir of Maithili literature' positions him in a subaltern counter-tradition to the Vidyapati padavali orthodoxy — the truth-teller who refuses the consolations of high aesthetic form. This reading needs qualification: Chaudhary is less an iconoclast of Maithili aesthetics than someone who has internalized those aesthetics and found ways to adapt them to the novel form. His prose rhythm in Maithili has been noted by multiple critics as unusually musical — a quality that suggests padavali influence on syntax rather than mere subject matter.

| Theory / Framework | Tradition | Application to Chaudhary |
|---|---|---|
| **Padavali** / | Vidyapati tradition; | Chaudhary's prose rhythm |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **Bhakti Aesthetics** | Navarasa theory | bears padavali influence. Hina deploys shringara-viraha in a secular frame; Abara Nahitan echoes the cosmic viraha of Radha's separation as cultural memory of the returned migrant. |

## 4.5 Progressive and Marxist Criticism (Pragativad)

The Progressivist literary movement in India (Pragativadi Sahitya Andolan), inaugurated by the All-India Progressive Writers' Association in 1936 and developed through critics such as Ramvilas Sharma and Namvar Singh, evaluates literature by its capacity to expose class contradiction, represent working-class experience, and advance social transformation. From this perspective, Chaudhary's novels have a complex relationship.

Mahur is the most susceptible to progressive reading: it traces how monetisation and urban migration corrode the cooperative structures of Maithili village life, rendering the family a site of exploitation rather than sustenance. Karar's preoccupation with contracts, agreements, and the commodification of relationships reads, through a progressive lens, as an analysis of how capitalist social relations penetrate and deform even intimate life. Abara Nahitan's protagonist is recognisably a product of international capital — the Indian technocrat or manager formed by American higher education and Middle Eastern employment — and his crisis is precisely the hollowness of that formation.

What distinguishes Chaudhary from orthodox progressive fiction is his refusal to offer programmatic resolution. His novels do not conclude with collective awakening, political solidarity, or revolutionary possibility. They end in qualified returns, muted recognitions, or unresolved tensions — a formal modesty that progressive critics have sometimes misread as ideological timidity, but which is more accurately understood as realist honesty about the limits of individual consciousness.

| Theory / | Tradition | Application to |
|---|---|---|

| Framework | | Chaudhary |
|---|---|---|
| **Pragativad (Progressivism)** | AIPWA; Ramvilas Sharma; Namvar Singh | Mahur and Karar expose capitalist penetration of intimate life. Abara Nahitan critiques the diaspora professional. Refuses programmatic resolution — honest about limits of individual praxis. |

## 4.6 Dalit and Subaltern Perspectives

The Dalit literary movement in India, which produced its most theoretically articulate criticism in Marathi (Om Prakash Valmiki, Sharankumar Limbale) and later in Telugu, Gujarati, and Hindi, asks of any literary text: whose experience does it centre? whose labour and pain does it make visible? By this criterion, Chaudhary's position is complex.

His protagonists are typically educated men from upper-caste Maithili families — Brahmin or Kayastha — who have benefited from the cultural capital that has historically excluded Dalit and OBC Maithilis from literary representation. This is the limitation that Videha's Parallel Literature framework identifies: the Sahitya Akademi-dominant Maithili literature centres a particular social stratum, and Chaudhary, despite his innovative technique, does not fundamentally disrupt this centering.

However, the secondary female characters in his novels — particularly in Chameli Rani and Abara Nahitan — often come from lower social positions and carry the novel's most incisive social commentary. Pradeep Bihari's essay in Videha 352 argues precisely this point: the title of his essay, 'Mukhya Patra Goun Vyatha: Abara Nahitan' (Main Character, Secondary Pain: Abara Nahitan), suggests that the novel's truest subject is the women who exist at the margins of its ostensible narrative.

| Theory / Framework | Tradition | Application to Chaudhary |
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|---|---|---|
| **Dalit / Subaltern Criticism** | Sharankumar Limbale (Towards an Aesthetic of Dalit Literature); Spivak | Protagonists from upper-caste formation. Secondary female characters carry subaltern critique. Pradeep Bihari reads Abara Nahitan against the grain: the women's marginal voices are the novel's real argument. |

## 4.7 Feminist and Stri-Vimarsh Criticism

Indian feminist literary criticism (Stri-vimarsh), developed through critics such as Maithreyi Krishnamurti, Susie Tharu, K. Lalita, and in Hindi through the journal Hans under Rajendra Yadav's editorship, asks how gender structures narrative form and social representation. Chaudhary's novels offer particularly rich material here.

All six novels place women at or near the narrative centre. Chameli Rani and Hina are named for their female protagonists; Ayna gives a woman's consciousness the organising metaphor of the text. The female characters in Chaudhary's novels are distinguished by a refusal of conventional Maithili feminine virtue — they are not the patient Sita, nor the self-sacrificing mother of the folk tradition, but complex persons who desire, judge, and choose. Abha Jha's reading of Hina as 'an extraordinary account of Advaita love' is essentially a feminist re-reading: the Advaita framework dissolves the gendered hierarchy of lover and beloved, subject and object.

The critical limitation from a feminist perspective is that these female characters, however complex, are frequently mediated through a male narrator or focalizer — the returned diaspora intellectual whose vision organises the text. The women are seen, rarely the sole seers. This is the structural constraint that a rigorous stri-vimarsh reading would identify: Chaudhary's feminism is sympathetic but not radical; it extends subjectivity to women while retaining the narrative architecture of the male gaze.

| Theory / | Tradition | Application to |
|---|---|---|

| Framework | | Chaudhary |
|---|---|---|
| **Stri-Vimarsh (Feminist Criticism)** | Susie Tharu; K. Lalita; Maithreyi Krishnamurti; Abha Jha (Videha 352) | Female protagonists refuse conventional Maithili femininity. Hina's Advaita framework dissolves lover/beloved hierarchy. Limitation: female characters often mediated through male focalizer — sympathetic but not radically feminist. |

5. Western Critical Frameworks

Western literary theory provides a complementary set of analytical instruments for reading Chaudhary's fiction. The following frameworks are applied not as universalising grids but as tools that illuminate specific aspects of the texts when used with attention to their Maithili cultural particularity.

## 5.1 Marxist and Lukácsian Realism

Georg Lukács's theory of the novel, articulated in The Theory of the Novel (1916) and Studies in European Realism (1950), holds that the great realist novel mediates between individual biography and social totality — using the fate of particular characters to reveal the structural determinations of their world. Lukács's hero is always 'problematic': a person whose inner aspirations are in conflict with the degraded world they inhabit.

Chaudhary's protagonists are paradigmatic Lukácsian problematic individuals. In Abara Nahitan, the returning male protagonist carries a fully formed inner world — formed by American education, Middle Eastern employment, global capital — that finds itself fundamentally incongruent with the Mithila he returns to. This incongruence is not resolved by the novel: it is its subject. The Maithili world is neither idealised as a refuge nor condemned as backward; it is presented in its full social complexity, including its own internal contradictions of caste, gender, and economic change.

Lukács's distinction between the 'classical realist' novel (which integrates the particular into the social whole) and 'naturalism' (which merely transcribes surfaces) is also applicable: Chaudhary is a classical realist in this sense. His novels are not photographic documentation of Maithili social conditions but structured explorations of how consciousness and circumstance interact.

| Theory / Framework | Tradition | Application to Chaudhary |
|---|---|---|
| **Lukácsian Realism** | Georg Lukács (Theory of the Novel; Studies in European Realism) | Protagonists are 'problematic individuals' whose inner world is in tension with social reality. Abara Nahitan typifies |

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| | | Lukácsian incongruence: diaspora-formed consciousness returned to transformed home. Classical realism, not naturalism. |

## 5.2 Bakhtinian Dialogism and the Novel

Mikhail Bakhtin's theory of the novel as an inherently dialogic form — in which multiple voices, social languages (raznorechie), and ideological positions coexist without being resolved into a single authoritative discourse — is highly productive for reading Chaudhary. The Dialogic Imagination (1981) and Problems of Dostoevsky's Poetics (1984) provide the key conceptual tools.

Chaudhary's narrative voice is conspicuously dialogic: it imports into Maithili prose the social languages of Californian academic English, Iranian Persian-inflected cultural discourse, Bombay Hindi urban vernacular, and Mithila Maithili. These do not merge into a unified narrative register; they remain in tension, producing what Bakhtin calls 'heteroglossia' — the productive conflict of languages within a single text. The protagonist of Abara Nahitan thinks partly in global English, speaks in Maithili, and remembers in the intimate code of Mithila folk culture — this is not inconsistency but social-linguistic realism.

Bakhtin's concept of the 'chronotope' — the spatiotemporal matrix in which novelistic events are embedded — is equally useful. Chaudhary's characteristic chronotope might be called the 'threshold of return': the moment of re-crossing from outside to inside, from global to local, from diaspora to home. This threshold is never completely crossed in any of his novels; the characters inhabit the liminal space, which generates the novels' characteristic tension.

| Theory / Framework | Tradition | Application to Chaudhary |
|---|---|---|
| **Dialogism / Heteroglossia** | Mikhail Bakhtin (Dialogic Imagination; Problems of Dostoevsky's Poetics) | Chaudhary's prose is heteroglossic: global English, Maithili vernacular, and folk |

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| | | idiom coexist in tension. The 'chronotope of the return threshold' organises Abara Nahitan and Ayna. Polyphonic without authorial resolution. |

## 5.3 Postcolonial Theory and the Subaltern

Homi Bhabha's concept of 'hybridity' and 'the third space' (The Location of Culture, 1994), and Gayatri Spivak's interrogation of who can speak and be heard (Can the Subaltern Speak?, 1988), both illuminate the structural situation of Chaudhary's writing.

Bhabha's 'third space' — the liminal space in which cultural meanings are negotiated rather than simply received — is precisely where Chaudhary's characters live. The returned diaspora intellectual is constitutively hybrid: formed by two or more cultural systems, at home in none of them completely, capable of a perspective unavailable to those who remained within a single cultural world. Chaudhary's Maithili, as noted above, is itself a hybrid language — a Maithili of the third space.

Spivak's framework raises harder questions. The subaltern in Chaudhary's Mithila — the landless labourer, the Dalit woman, the lower-caste artisan — does not speak in his novels. They are present in the social landscape of the texts but rarely given narrative voice. Chaudhary's fiction speaks about the subaltern condition but not with or from it. This is the postcolonial limitation that locates his work within, rather than beyond, the colonial-era Maithili literary formation.

| Theory / Framework | Tradition | Application to Chaudhary |
|---|---|---|
| **Postcolonial Theory** | Homi Bhabha (Location of Culture); Gayatri Spivak (Can the Subaltern Speak?) | Protagonists inhabit Bhabha's 'third space' of hybrid cultural formation. Maithili itself is a third- |

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|---|---|---|
| | | space language in his prose. Spivakian limitation: subaltern presence but no subaltern voice — the class formation of the narrator occludes lower-caste experience. |

## 5.4 Existentialism and Alienation

Jean-Paul Sartre's analysis of bad faith (mauvaise foi) and radical freedom, Albert Camus's absurdist aesthetics, and more broadly the existentialist tradition's concern with the isolated consciousness confronting a meaningless world, find an unexpected echo in Chaudhary's Maithili fiction.

The male protagonists of Mahur and Abara Nahitan exhibit what Sartre would recognise as the 'situation' of radical freedom with no adequate project — they have escaped the determinations of their origin (village, caste, family network) through education and migration, but the freedom gained has not produced a viable alternative identity. The 'poison' of Mahur is precisely this: the toxin of meaninglessness that enters the family system when its members begin to treat each other as means rather than ends. Chaudhary does not use existentialist vocabulary, but the phenomenology of his fictional world is recognisably existentialist in its concern with authenticity, bad faith, and the nausea of self-consciousness.

Camus's 'absurd hero' — who confronts meaninglessness without flinching and continues to act without consoling illusions — is a useful analogue for the female characters of Chameli Rani and Hina. These women do not capitulate to social pressure, nor do they find transcendent consolation; they persist in their choices with a quiet clarity that Camus would recognise as a form of revolt.

| Theory / Framework | Tradition | Application to Chaudhary |
|---|---|---|
| **Existentialism** | Sartre (Being and Nothingness); Camus | Male protagonists enact 'bad faith' — freedom |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | (The Myth of Sisyphus) | without viable project. Mahur diagnoses the poison of instrumentalising family relations. Female characters in Chameli Rani and Hina approximate the Camusian absurd hero: clear-eyed persistence without consolation. |

## 5.5 Psychoanalytic and Lacanian Readings

Sigmund Freud's theory of unconscious desire, the return of the repressed, and the role of mourning in the psychological economy; Jacques Lacan's reformulation of these in terms of desire, the Other, and the imaginary/symbolic/real triad: these frameworks open productive readings of Chaudhary's novelistic preoccupations.

The recurring figure of return in Chaudhary's fiction — across all six novels, characters return to homes, relationships, or cultural memories they thought left behind — is susceptible to a Freudian reading as the compulsion to repeat (Wiederholungszwang). The repressed cultural identity of the diaspora intellectual returns with the force of the unconscious; it cannot be voluntarily chosen or discarded. In Lacanian terms, the protagonist of Abara Nahitan is structured by desire for an object (home, belonging, recognition) that is constitutively unavailable — the objet petit a that can never be possessed, only circled.

Hina's Advaita framework can be read as an unconscious engagement with what Lacan calls the Imaginary register — the realm of the mirror, identification, and the illusion of wholeness. The love relationship in Hina seeks to overcome the fundamental dividedness of the subject, to achieve the non-dual wholeness that Advaita philosophy promises. That this attempt is possible only in fantasy — in the idealized space of romantic love — is the novel's melancholy insight.

| Theory / Framework | Tradition | Application to Chaudhary |
|---|---|---|
| **Psychoanalysis / Lacan** | Freud (Beyond the Pleasure Principle); Lacan (Ecrits; The Four Fundamental Concepts) | Return as compulsion to repeat (Wiederholungszwang). Protagonist of Abara Nahitan circles the objet petit a of impossible belonging. Hina's Advaita framework engages the Lacanian Imaginary: the romantic ideal of non-dual wholeness is a mirror-stage illusion. |

## 5.6 Narratology: Genette and Booth

Gérard Genette's Narrative Discourse (1980) — with its categories of narrative time, mode, and voice — and Wayne Booth's The Rhetoric of Fiction (1961) — with its concepts of implied author, unreliable narrator, and narrative distance — provide technical instruments for analysing Chaudhary's narrative method.

Chaudhary's handling of narrative time is notable for its use of analepsis (flashback) and ellipsis. Ayna proceeds as a series of retrospective illuminations in which the present of narration is constantly interrupted by a past that refuses to remain past — a temporal structure that formally enacts the content of civilisational memory and decay. In Abara Nahitan, Genette's distinction between 'story time' and 'discourse time' is particularly illuminating: the discourse lingers on episodes of encounter and conversation that are brief in story time, while compressing years of diaspora existence into a few sentences. This temporal asymmetry signals where the novel's values lie: in the quality of attention, not the quantity of event.

Booth's concept of the 'unreliable narrator' is applicable to several Chaudhary protagonists: they tell their stories with confidence, but the reader accumulates evidence of blind spots, self-deceptions, and gaps that the narrator does not acknowledge. This unreliability is not moral (the narrators are not dishonest) but epistemological: they know what they know, and the novels track what they cannot know about themselves.

| Theory / Framework | Tradition | Application to Chaudhary |
|---|---|---|
| **Narratology** | Gérard Genette (Narrative Discourse); Wayne Booth (Rhetoric of Fiction) | Temporal analepsis as formal enactment of cultural memory (Ayna). Discourse time lingers on encounter, compresses diaspora years — signals where novelistic value lies. Epistemologically unreliable narrators: confident but blind to own self-deceptions. |

## 5.7 Postmodernism and Metafiction

While Chaudhary is not a postmodern writer in the Pynchon or Calvino sense, elements of what Linda Hutcheon calls 'historiographic metafiction' — fiction that is self-conscious about its own status as construction while engaging seriously with historical reality — are visible in Ayna. The mirror as governing metaphor raises questions about the status of the image it produces: is the 'Mithila' reflected in the novel a direct representation of reality, or a constructed image that shapes how reality is perceived?

More relevant is Fredric Jameson's analysis of 'late capitalism' and its cultural logic (Postmodernism, or, the Cultural Logic of Late Capitalism, 1991). Jameson argues that late capitalism produces a characteristic cultural condition of pastiche, depthlessness, and the waning of affect. Chaudhary's diagnosis of Mithila under modernity shares something with this analysis: the 'poison' of Mahur is precisely the depthlessness of commodified relationships; the 'mirror' of Ayna is precisely the pastiche surface of a culture that has lost its originary depth.

| Theory / Framework | Tradition | Application to Chaudhary |
|---|---|---|

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **Postmodernism / Late Capitalism** | Linda Hutcheon (Historiographic Metafiction); Fredric Jameson (Postmodernism) | Ayna's mirror motif raises metafictional questions about representation. Mahur's 'poison' and Ayna's 'decay' diagnose Mithila under late capitalism's logic of commodification and depthlessness (Jameson). |

# 6. Synthesised Critical Assessment

Bringing the Indian and Western frameworks into dialogue produces a more complete critical picture than either tradition yields alone. The following synthesis organises the key findings by theme.

## 6.1 The Diaspora Novel in a Regional Language

Chaudhary's most distinctive contribution to Indian literature is the creation of a diaspora novel in a regional language. The Indian diaspora novel in English (Salman Rushdie, Amitav Ghosh, Jhumpa Lahiri) is a well-established genre; the same genre in a regional vernacular is almost non-existent. Chaudhary's six novels constitute a solitary body of work that maps the experience of international migration, alienation, and return onto a Maithili cultural and linguistic frame.

This singularity gives his work both its peculiar strength and its institutional marginalisation. Within the Maithili literary establishment, which has historically celebrated village-rooted writing in the idiom of folk tradition and padavali aesthetics, Chaudhary's globally inflected fiction was never fully at home. Within the English-language discourse on the Indian diaspora novel, it remains invisible due to the language barrier. The Videha Parallel Literature framework is the first critical institution to recognise and theorise this double marginalisation.

> *The Maithili novel of Kedar Nath Chaudhary is one of the almost completely unrecognised creations of Indian literature of the period 2000–2020. The canon of the Indian novel does not accommodate works that are neither in a major regional language nor in English.*
>
> **— Ashish Anchinhar, Videha 352 (paraphrased)**

## 6.2 Female Interiority as Literary Innovation

The most consistently praised aspect of Chaudhary's fiction across all critics in the Videha special issue is his handling of female interiority. This is simultaneously the most significant literary achievement and the most contested terrain from a feminist-theoretical perspective. The novels grant

women psychological complexity and moral autonomy that was comparatively rare in Maithili prose fiction before Chaudhary. But this granting is itself an act of authorial generosity — it comes from a male writer looking at women, however sympathetically, rather than from women writing their own experience.

The Indian feminist tradition's distinction between 'writing the female' and 'women's writing' is directly applicable here. Chaudhary writes the female with unusual skill and compassion; his novels are not, and could not be, women's writing. The distinction matters for how the novels are placed in literary history: they belong to a tradition of male authors who have taken women seriously (Flaubert, Tolstoy, in Indian literature Premchand, in Maithili Harimohan Jha) rather than to the emergent Maithili women's literary movement represented by writers like Shefali Varma, whose work also appears in the Videha archive.

## 6.3 Mithila as Palimpsest

All six novels treat Mithila not as a static setting but as a palimpsest — a surface on which multiple historical layers are simultaneously legible. The classical Mithila of Vidyapati and Jyotirishwar, the colonial Mithila of the late 19th and early 20th centuries, the post-Independence Bihar of increasing underdevelopment, and the contemporary Mithila of outmigration, flood, and cultural commodification: these layers are all present in Chaudhary's fictional world, visible at different depths depending on where the narrative digs.

This palimpsestic quality connects Chaudhary to both the Indian concept of smriti (memory as collective inheritance) and to Walter Benjamin's theory of the dialectical image — the flash in which the past is suddenly legible in the present. Benjamin's 'Now of recognisability' (Jetzt der Erkennbarkeit) describes the moment in Ayna when the mirror reflects not just the present but the accumulated weight of civilisational history.

| Theory / Framework | Tradition | Application to Chaudhary |
|---|---|---|
| **Palimpsest / Cultural Memory** | Walter Benjamin (Theses on the Philosophy of History); Smriti tradition | Mithila in Chaudhary's fiction is a palimpsest of classical, colonial, post- |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | | Independence, and contemporary layers. Ayna's dialectical image: the mirror as 'Now of recognisability' in which civilisational memory becomes visible. |

## 6.4 The Question of the 'Kedar Nath Era'

Ashish Anchinhar's proposal of a 'Kedar Nath Yug' (era) in Maithili fiction — made in his Videha 352 essay — rests on the claim that Chaudhary's novels collectively open a new phase characterised by: (a) global cultural reference without loss of Maithili specificity; (b) psychological realism of a depth not previously sustained in Maithili prose; (c) willingness to address taboo social realities including the failure of marriage, the hollowness of professional success, and the moral compromises of the educated class; and (d) a new prose rhythm that brings literary Maithili closer to spoken usage without sacrificing literary density.

Whether this constitutes a 'Yug' in the full literary-historical sense — as the Chayavad Yug or Nayi Kahani constitute eras in Hindi literature — depends on whether Chaudhary's innovations generate a school or a tradition. The evidence of the Videha archive suggests that his influence on younger Maithili novelists is real but as yet not institutionally recognised. If Videha's critical project succeeds in placing his work in the Maithili literary curriculum, the 'Kedar Nath Yug' may indeed become a scholarly category.

## 7. Critical Voices: Scholars in Videha 352

The Videha Kedar Nath Chaudhary Visheshank (Issue 352) brought together twenty-four critical contributions. The following is a selective assessment of the most significant:

### 7.1 Kalpana Jha: 'Ieha Gur Khene, Kan Chedaune'

The longest and most wide-ranging critical essay in the issue, Kalpana Jha's contribution reads Chaudhary's novels through a close attention to their female characters across all six texts. Her title — a Maithili proverb equivalent to 'once you've tasted jaggery, you'll get your ears pierced' — captures the addictive quality of Chaudhary's fiction. Her method is close reading combined with feminist attentiveness to what women are permitted to do and say in each novel.

### 7.2 Ashish Anchinhar: 'Maithili Upanyas Kar Kedar Nath Yug'

The most theoretically ambitious essay in the issue, proposing the 'Kedar Nath Yug' as a historical category. Anchinhar draws on his deep knowledge of Maithili literary history (as author of the standard work on Maithili ghazal grammar and the history of Maithili web journalism) to situate Chaudhary's innovation within the long arc of Maithili prose development from Harimohan Jha's Kanyadan and Rajkamal Chaudhary's Andolan.

### 7.3 Arvind Thakur: 'Vilakshan Ken Vyakhyayit Karab: Abara Nahitan'

The most philosophically sustained reading of the key novel, Arvind Thakur's essay (22 pages, the longest devoted to a single work) brings Advaita Vedanta, Buddhist philosophy of dependent origination, and close narrative analysis to bear on Abara Nahitan. He reads the novel's title as a koan: the wanderer who is not-wandering is the person who has discovered that home and exile are not opposites but interdependent categories.

### 7.4 Gajendra Thakur: 'Kedar Nath Chaudhary — Hunak aa Hunak Upanyas Kar Punapath'

The editor's own essay is a model of the rereading methodology central to Videha's critical project. 'Punapath' (re-reading) signals that the essay's purpose is not first evaluation but reconsideration of works that have been inadequately read. Thakur argues that Chaudhary's novels resist easy summary precisely because their meaning is distributed across multiple levels of dhvani rather than concentrated in explicit statement — a claim that connects the editor's critical framework to the classical Indian theory of suggestion.

### 7.5 Pradeep Bihari: 'Mukhya Patra Goun Vyatha'

Pradeep Bihari's reading of Abara Nahitan is the most politically acute in the volume. By reversing the conventional centre-periphery relation of novelistic analysis — insisting that the 'secondary characters' and their pain are the main subject — he performs a subaltern-studies manoeuvre on the text: the novel means more than its narrator knows.

## 8. Conclusion: Towards a Fuller Critical Recognition

Kedar Nath Chaudhary represents a genuinely significant, genuinely neglected body of literary achievement in modern Indian literature. His six novels constitute the only sustained attempt to write the Indian diaspora experience through the Maithili language and cultural frame. This double specificity — diaspora experience made Maithili; Mithila culture seen through a globally formed consciousness — produces a literary terrain that existing critical frameworks, whether of the Indian regional language tradition or the English-language postcolonial novel, have not adequately mapped.

The application of Indian classical frameworks — rasa theory, dhvani, auchitya, progressive and feminist criticism — reveals the depth of his rootedness in Maithili aesthetic and social traditions even when his subject matter is the disruption of those traditions. The application of Western frameworks — Lukácsian realism, Bakhtinian dialogism, postcolonial theory, psychoanalysis, narratology — reveals the modernity of his formal achievement and its comparability with world literature of the period 1960–2020.

What neither tradition has yet fully accomplished is the reading of Chaudhary as a figure who demands both frameworks simultaneously — who cannot be understood through either alone. This is precisely the challenge that the Videha Parallel Literature Movement has begun to address, and that the present report attempts to advance.

> *A writer who returned to Maithili late, after a life lived between continents, and found in that language a form adequate to the full complexity of that life — this is Kedar Nath Chaudhary's achievement, and its recognition is overdue.*
>
> **— Editorial paraphrase, Gajendra Thakur, Videha 352**

**Bibliography & Primary Sources**

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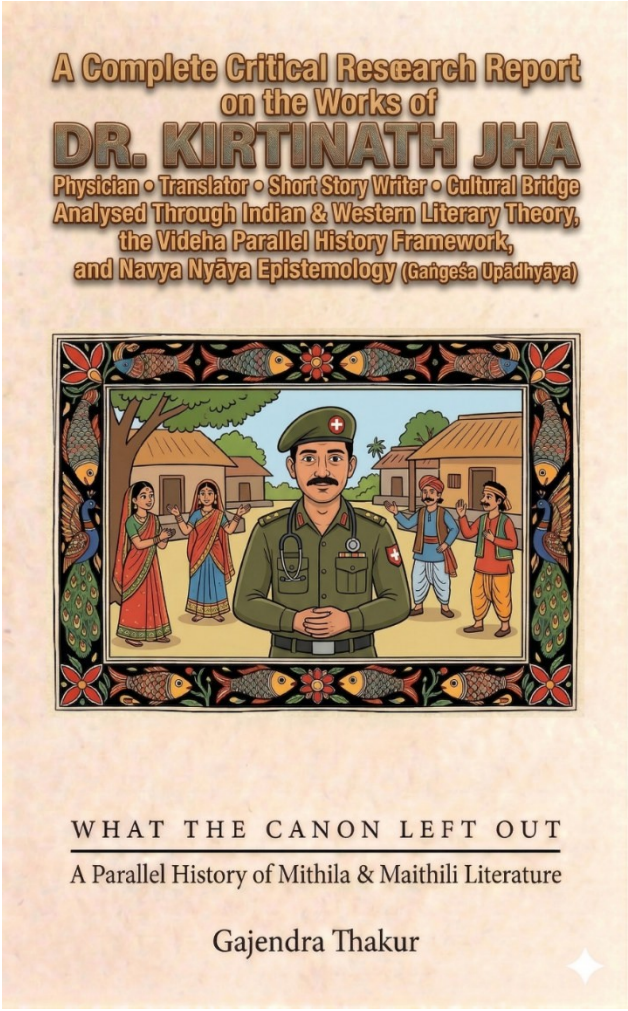
*Videha Pothi Archive: https://www.videha.co.in/pothi.htm*

*Indian classical frameworks: Bharata Muni, Natyashastra; Anandavardhana, Dhvanyaloka; Kuntaka, Vakroktijivita; Kshemendra, Auchityavichara; Abhinavagupta, Abhinavabharati.*

*Western frameworks: Lukács, Theory of the Novel; Bakhtin, Dialogic Imagination; Bhabha, Location of Culture; Spivak, Can the Subaltern Speak?; Genette, Narrative Discourse; Booth, Rhetoric of Fiction; Jameson, Postmodernism.*

**LESSON 038 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**




## *A Complete Critical Research Report*

*on the Works of*

**DR. KIRTINATH JHA**

*Physician • Translator • Short Story Writer • Cultural Bridge*

Analysed Through Indian & Western Literary Theory,

the Videha Parallel History Framework,

and Navya Nyāya Epistemology (Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya)

I. INTRODUCTION

Dr. Kirtinath Jha occupies a distinctive position in the landscape of contemporary Maithili literature. A physician by profession — working at Mahatma Gandhi Medical College and Research Institute, Puducherry — he exemplifies the phenomenon of the scholar-healer who carries the burden of dual identity: scientific practitioner and literary artist. His published works available through the Videha archive (www.videha.co.in) encompass at least two major books: the short-story collection Kichu Puran Gapa Kichu Nava Gapa (2005; "Some Old Stories, Some New Stories") and the Maithili translation of Khalil Gibran's celebrated novella Broken Wings, rendered as Tutal Pankhi (2016; "Broken Wings"), the latter published from Darbhanga by Printvell Press.

This critical report traces the authorial identity, creative range, thematic preoccupations, and translatorial craft of Dr. Jha through three interlocking analytical lenses: (1) classical Indian criticism rooted in the rasa-dhvani-alamkara tradition as refined by Navya Nyaya epistemology, especially the thought of Gangesa Upadhyaya; (2) the Videha Parallel History Framework developed by Gajendra Thakur; and (3) key Western literary theories including Romanticism, Structuralism, Post-colonialism, and Translation Studies. The synthesis of these frames allows us to place Jha's contributions in both their immediate Maithili cultural context and the broader world literary conversation.

## II. BIOGRAPHICAL AND SCHOLARLY CONTEXT

### 2.1 The Author's Life and Location

Kirtinath Jha's institutional affiliation with Mahatma Gandhi Medical College and Research Institute, Puducherry (Pondicherry) — a Union Territory of

former French colonial influence in South India — is itself significant. It situates him as a member of the Maithili diaspora, far removed geographically from the Mithila heartland of Bihar and the Tarai region of Nepal, yet deeply tethered to his linguistic and cultural roots. His email address (kirtinath.jha@gmail.com) and telephone number (0413-2615568) appear on the colophon of Tutal Pankhi, reflecting a characteristic openness of Videha-associated authors to scholarly communication.

The dedication of Tutal Pankhi to the memory of the eminent scholar Prof. Dr. Bheemnath Jha ("Bheemababu") — described in the preface as having "read the Maithili manuscript with affectionate care and suggested improvements" — signals the author's embeddedness within academic Maithili scholarship and the tradition of collaborative intellectual labour that characterises the Videha movement.

## 2.2 The Videha Publication Ecosystem

Both works under study appear in the Videha archive (www.videha.co.in/pothi.htm), which is the primary digital repository for Maithili books established as part of the Videha Maithili Fortnightly eJournal (ISSN 2229-547X), founded in 2000 and associated principally with the writer-scholar Gajendra Thakur. Videha's explicit mission is to document, preserve, and critically evaluate Maithili literary production. Its Parallel History section, accessible at www.videha.co.in/gajenthakur.htm, has published critical studies of dozens of Maithili authors — including essays on Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil', Ramlochan Thakur, Subhash Chandra Yadav, Arvind Thakur, Ashok, Ram Bharos Kapari 'Bhramar', Narendra Jha, Panna Jha, and others — making it the most systematic ongoing critical project in modern Maithili letters.

## 2.3 The Kichu Puran Gapa Kichu Nava Gapa (2005) Short-Story Collection

First noted in published criticism around 2005, Kichu Puran Gapa Kichu Nava Gapa ('Some Old Stories, Some New Stories') represents Kirtinath Jha's contribution to what scholars of Maithili literature have described as a period of great creative fertility in the 21st century short story. Academic surveys of the Maithili short story (e.g., the critical overview published by the International Journal of Creative Research Thoughts, 2025) explicitly list this collection among the significant contributions of the decade. The title itself is epistemologically programmed: the binary old/new invites the reader to ask

what constitutes newness in narrative. This is precisely the kind of question that Navya Nyaya technique (discussed below) is equipped to resolve.

### 2.4 Tutal Pankhi (2016): The Translation Project

Kirtinath Jha's Maithili rendering of Khalil Gibran's Broken Wings (al-Ajniha al-Mutakassira, 1912) — Tutal Pankhi ("Broken Wings") — is described in its preface as a project born of deep personal affinity. Jha states that upon reading the original (presumably in English translation), he was so moved that he read it several more times and "became influenced", ultimately deciding to publish a Maithili translation. The work is dedicated to Prof. Dr. Bheemnath Jha, who assisted with manuscript review. The colophon lists the price as Rs. 100 and the publisher as Printvell Press, Darbhanga — the cultural capital of Mithila. Its first edition appeared in 2016.

## III. KHALIL GIBRAN'S BROKEN WINGS: SOURCE TEXT ANALYSIS

### 3.1 Gibran and the Arabic Literary Renaissance

Khalil Gibran (1883–1931) was born in Bsharri, Lebanon (then part of Ottoman Syria), to a poor Christian family. His biography is inseparable from the condition of diaspora: emigrating to Boston in his youth, returning to Beirut for schooling, and eventually settling in Paris and New York. His encounter with the Bahá'í reformer 'Abdul Bahá profoundly shaped his syncretic Sufi-inflected mysticism. Broken Wings, published in Arabic in 1912 — though composed earlier — is regarded as Gibran's finest work in Arabic and as a cornerstone of the modern Arabic literary renaissance (al-Nahda).

The work is autobiographical in origin. The probable model for Selma Karamy, the tragic heroine, is Hala al-Dahir, Gibran's first love, whose family discouraged the relationship. The narrative unfolds in ten chapters, voiced by an unnamed young man (clearly a stand-in for Gibran) who falls in love with Selma, daughter of Farris Effandi Karamy, a gentle, wealthy but weak-willed older man. Their love is tragically destroyed when the local bishop — representing clerical corruption and patriarchal power — forces Selma to marry his greedy nephew Mansour Bey. The lovers meet secretly at a Phoenician temple of Ishtar/Astarte ('Eshtar in Gibran's orthography), until Selma dies in

childbirth, her infant also dead. The novel ends with the narrator weeping over her grave.

### 3.2 Themes

The central themes of Broken Wings include:

- Tragic love and social constraint: The central love is doomed not by interior flaw but by institutional power — the church and its corruption.
- Critique of clerical and patriarchal authority: The bishop is painted as a hypocrite who uses religious office for personal gain; women are treated as commodities.
- Eastern womanhood: Selma's beauty, silence, and self-sacrifice are presented with both admiring and proto-feminist ambivalence.
- Nature mysticism: Lebanese cedar forests, mountains, moonlit gardens, and sea provide a Romantic backdrop that fuses Sufi symbolism with Romantic landscape aesthetics.
- Death as liberation: Selma's death is narratively constructed as liberation from earthly bondage.

### 3.3 Narrative Style and Poetic Prose

Gibran's prose in Broken Wings is characteristically lyrical — dense with simile, metaphor, parallelism, and apostrophe. The sentence rhythms mimic biblical cadence, reflecting his deep familiarity with both the Arabic Quran and the Christian Bible. Critics have compared his style to that of Dante (for its mystical architecture) and Rousseau (for its romantic self-exposure). His figurative language makes translation into any language a creative act of extraordinary delicacy.

> *"My neighbours, you remember the dawn of youth with pleasure and regret its passing; but I remember it like a prisoner who recalls the bars and shackles of his jail." — Gibran, Broken Wings (opening line)*

## IV. TUTAL PANKHI: CLOSE READING OF THE MAITHILI TRANSLATION

## 4.1 The Title and Its Maithili Resonance

The Maithili title Tutal Pankhi (टूटल पाँखि) renders the English "Broken Wings" with remarkable directness. Tutal (टूटल) derives from the Maithili-Sanskrit verbal root tut- (to break, to snap), carrying connotations of fracture that are at once physical and metaphysical. Pankhi (पाँखि) means "bird" or "wing" (from Sanskrit paksha), and in Maithili folk idiom is associated with freedom, the soul, and yearning. The compound Tutal Pankhi thus achieves in two words what the English title achieves — the image of flight arrested by violence — while also activating the specifically Maithili imaginative tradition of the bird-soul (jivatma as pankhi) that runs from medieval Charyapada poetry through Vidyapati's devotional verse.

The title participates in what the Videha Parallel History Framework calls "memory-embedding" — the capacity of a literary text to activate inherited cultural memory in its new linguistic home. In this instance, Maithili readers encounter Gibran's Lebanese bird not as an exotic import but as a cousin of their own indigenous bird-soul symbolism.

## 4.2 Structural Fidelity and Creative Expansion

Tutal Pankhi preserves the ten-chapter structure of the original (Pratham adhyay through Dasam adhyay in the Maithili text). A close reading of the opening chapter in the Maithili version reveals how Jha navigates between two translatorial imperatives: faithfulness to Gibran's meaning and adaptation to Maithili linguistic and cultural norms.

Consider the original's opening: Gibran describes his youth as a time of involuntary solitude — not from lack of friends, but from an inner disposition. Jha renders this:

> *"PaD'osi loka ! yauvanak āgaman keṇ harash saṃ ā ekar avasān keṃ ahaṃ duḥkha saṃ smaraṇa karait chī. Kintu hama ! hamara ekar anubhūti ekatā bandhi jakāṃ bhēl achi jakara mātra okar kaŏiyā ā beḍhīk smaraṇa hoibat achī." [Tutal Pankhi, Chapter 1, p.9]*

The Maithili here is fluid, the syntax following Maithili SOB (Subject-Object-Verb) word order rather than Arabic/English structures. The choice of bandhi (prison, bondage) for "jail" is notably earthier than a more Sanskritised equivalent would be, aligning with Jha's general strategy of preferring colloquial Maithili. The phrase kaDiyā ā beDī ("bars and shackles") renders the original's image with direct equivalents that would resonate viscerally for

Maithili readers familiar with the imagery of imprisonment from vernacular literature.

## 4.3 The Preface as Critical Act

Kirtinath Jha's preface (bhūmikā) to Tutal Pankhi constitutes a small but significant critical essay in its own right. He introduces Gibran's life: born 1883 in Bsharri, Lebanon; family emigrated to Boston; Jha describes the social environment of Lebanon under Ottoman rule as characterised by "economic destitution, political repression, and religious misconduct". He traces Gibran's artistic formation, his mentor Mary Haskell, his years in Paris, and his death in New York in 1931 at age 48. The preface correctly notes that Gibran's international fame rests above all on The Prophet (1923).

Crucially, Jha notes in the preface that this is the FIRST Maithili translation of any work by Gibran. He writes: "Whether any Maithili translation of Gibran's works exists or not, we could not determine [from our inquiry]." This historical claim, if verified, gives Tutal Pankhi the additional significance of a cultural first — a gateway text opening Maithili literary culture to one of the twentieth century's most widely read world authors.

## 4.4 Language, Diction, and Register

Throughout the translation, Jha deploys a mixed register that blends Sanskrit-derived Maithili vocabulary with vernacular idioms. This reflects the layered linguistic situation of written Maithili, which operates across a spectrum from the highly Sanskritised (Gramī or literary standard) to the colloquial. Jha's practice leans toward a middle register that would be accessible to educated readers while retaining the aesthetic elevation appropriate to Gibran's poetic prose.

Nature imagery is particularly well rendered. The Lebanese landscape of Broken Wings — cedar forests (sarva/devdāru), moonlit mountains, the Mediterranean sea — is translated with Maithili equivalents that evoke the Gangetic plains landscape familiar to Jha's readers. Where Gibran's Beirut spring (described in Chapter 2, the month of Nisan) is rendered through Maithili spring ('vasanta') imagery, the cultural translation works because the season of renewal and flowering carries analogous symbolic weight in both traditions.

# V. INDIAN CRITICAL FRAMEWORK: RASA, DHVANI, AND ALANKARA

## 5.1 The Rasa Theory Applied to Tutal Pankhi

The foundational framework of classical Indian aesthetics is the rasa theory, systematised by Bharata Muni in the Natyashastra (c. 2nd century BCE – 2nd century CE) and refined by subsequent theorists. Rasa — literally "taste" or "flavour" — denotes the aesthetic emotion or sentiment evoked in the sahridaya (receptive reader). Bharata identified eight primary rasas; later tradition added a ninth. Of these, Tutal Pankhi is overwhelmingly dominated by:

- Shringara rasa (the erotic / love sentiment): The love between the narrator and Selma, characterised by tenderness, longing, and spiritual elevation, provides the primary aesthetic colour of the work.
- Karuna rasa (the pathetic / compassionate sentiment): Selma's suffering under forced marriage, her stoic acceptance of fate, and her death generate profound pathos.
- Vibhatsa rasa (the odious / repulsive sentiment): The bishop and Mansour Bey's corruption and greed are depicted with a controlled disgust that heightens the moral contrast.

The shringara in Gibran's original — and therefore in Jha's translation — is of the vipralambha shringara subtype (love-in-separation), which classical theorists from Bharata onwards considered the more aesthetically potent mode, since longing intensifies emotion in ways that union cannot. The lovers in Broken Wings are united only briefly; their deeper communion is spiritual and expressed in language: Selma's silence is itself a mode of eloquence, and their love letters are composed in silence under the cedar trees.

Abhinavagupta (10th–11th century Kashmir), the greatest elaborator of rasa theory, argued in his Abhinavabharati that rasa arises through the process of sādhāraṇīkaraṇa — the universalisation of individual emotion. The reader's personal experiences of love and loss are "de-particularised" and elevated to the level of aesthetic savoring. Jha's translation preserves this universalising quality. By rendering the Lebanese landscape, culture, and characters into Maithili idiom without domesticating them entirely, he creates a productive tension that enables Maithili readers to experience sādhāraṇīkaraṇa in relation to both the familiar and the foreign.

## 5.2 Dhvani and Suggestiveness in Jha's Translation

Anandavardhana's Dhvanyaloka (9th century) introduced the concept of dhvani (resonance or suggestion) as the soul of poetry. On this theory, the highest literary expression works not through explicit statement but through what is implied — the "sound that echoes beyond the text." Three levels of meaning are distinguished: abhidhā (literal), lakshaṇā (secondary/metaphorical), and vyṅjanā (suggestive).

In Tutal Pankhi, the title itself operates at all three levels: (1) literally, birds with broken wings who cannot fly; (2) metaphorically, Selma and the narrator whose love has been broken by social forces; (3) suggestively, the very condition of the soul (ātmā as pankhi) imprisoned in a world that punishes beauty and love. Jha's translation preserves and in some instances enhances these dhvani layers by activating Maithili's rich heritage of bird-soul symbolism.

The recurrence of the image of the bird throughout the text — Selma compared at various points to a free bird, a bird in a cage, a wounded bird — gains additional resonance in Maithili because the pankhi/pakshi motif is deeply embedded in Maithili folk song (lok-geet), in Vidyapati's verse, and in the Charyapada Buddhist poems that are among the earliest ancestors of the Maithili literary tradition.

## 5.3 Alankara: Figurative Language in Translation

The Alankara (figure of speech) tradition, systematised by Bhamaha (7th century), Dandin (7th–8th century), and Mammata (11th century), provides tools for evaluating figurative language. Gibran's original abounds in:

- Rupaka (metaphor): "Your tears that are like the dew-drops of the morning."
- Upama (simile): "I remember [my youth] like a prisoner who recalls the bars and shackles of his jail."
- Anaphora (repetition): The parallel sentence structures that accumulate emotional force.
- Apostrophe: Direct address to God, to Lebanon, to the spirit of Selma.

Jha's handling of these figures in Maithili is generally skillful. Similes are retained with their structural markers (jakaṃ, jenu in Maithili). Metaphors are domesticated where necessary but rarely flattened. The apostrophes to God — particularly Selma's prayer in Chapter 6, where she cries out to the deity in a series of rhetorical questions — are translated with sustained emotional intensity, preserving what Gibran scholars call the "prophet-voice" quality of the original.

# VI. NAVYA NYĀYA EPISTEMOLOGICAL FRAMEWORK: GANGESA UPADHYAYA

## 6.1 Gangesa and the Mithila Intellectual Tradition

The application of Navya Nyaya epistemology to literary criticism is not a mere academic exercise — it is a historically grounded operation, for Gangesa Upadhyaya (c. first half of the 14th century) was himself a son of Mithila. Born at Karion village on the banks of the Kamala River, 19 km south-east of Darbhanga (the cultural capital of Mithila and home of the Printvell Press that published Jha's Tutal Pankhi), Gangesa represents the intellectual peak of the Mithila philosophical tradition. His Tattvacintamani ("Jewel of Thought on the Nature of Things", also known as Pramanacintamani, "Jewel of Thought on the Means of Valid Knowledge") founded the Navya Nyaya school of New Logic and established the most rigorous epistemological framework in classical Indian philosophy.

The Tattvacintamani is divided into four khandas (books) corresponding to the four pramanas (valid means of knowledge): Pratyaksa (perception), Anumana (inference), Upamana (comparison), and Shabda (verbal testimony). It is in the application of these four pramanas to literary analysis that Navya Nyaya offers the most productive entry into Jha's work.

## 6.2 Pratyaksa (Perception) Applied to Jha's Literary Universe

Pratyaksa (direct perception) in the Nyaya framework denotes cognition produced through sense-contact. In literary epistemology, this maps onto the question: what does the text make directly perceptible? Gangesa distinguishes between savikalpaka pratyaksa (determinate perception, where the object is identified and categorised) and nirvikalpaka pratyaksa (indeterminate perception, the raw, pre-conceptual sensory intake).

In Tutal Pankhi, the descriptions of Beirut's landscape in spring, the Phoenician temple, Selma's appearance, the moonlit gardens — all these function as literary pratyaksa. What Jha achieves in translation is the conversion of Gibran's Arabic sensory world into Maithili savikalpaka categories: the Lebanese mountain-garden is rendered through the Maithili reader's available perceptual categories (pahar, vatika, candan tree, moonlight) while preserving enough foreignness to mark the scene as "not-Mithila". This is what translation

theorists Lawrence Venuti would call a strategic exoticisation — a refusal of total domestication that forces the reader to expand their perceptual world.

In Navya Nyaya terms, Jha's translation produces a form of paroksha (indirect perception) in the Maithili reader: they "perceive" Beirut through the mediating screen of Maithili language, an experience that is epistemologically richer than simple equivalence would allow.

## 6.3 Anumana (Inference) and the Architecture of Plot

Anumana (inference), the second pramana, involves reasoning from a sign (linga) to its referent. Gangesa analyses vyapti (universal concomitance: "where there is smoke, there is fire") as the foundation of valid inference. In literary application, inference concerns how readers move from narrative signs to interpretive conclusions. The plot of Broken Wings is structured through chains of inference that the reader performs continuously: the bishop's corrupt character is inferred from his actions; Mansour Bey's greed is established by signs; the inevitability of tragedy is inferred from the structural tension between love and power.

Jha's translation preserves and indeed reinforces these inferential chains. In the chapter describing the bishop's nocturnal visit to the Karamy household (Chapter 5), the Maithili renders the dark symbolism — night, secrecy, authority — with vocabulary that activates Maithili folk associations with malevolent authority (the dakait, the corrupt zamindar), enabling Maithili readers to perform the necessary inferences through culturally proximate sign-systems.

## 6.4 Upamana (Comparison) and the Work of Translation Itself

Upamana (comparison) — knowledge derived from recognizing resemblance between a known and an unknown object — is particularly apt as a framework for understanding the act of translation. Gangesa's analysis of upamana involves a triadic structure: the known object (A), the unknown object (B), and the feature (f) shared between them. In translation, the source-text world is A, the target-text world is B, and the translator's task is to identify and transfer the shared features (f) while adjusting for what cannot be shared.

Kirtinath Jha's upamana work is visible in the dedication page and preface of Tutal Pankhi: he performs a sustained comparison between Lebanese and Maithili experience, arguing implicitly that love, loss, clerical corruption, and the subjugation of women are shared features (f) that make Gibran's world

legible in Mithila. The Phoenician goddess Astarte / Eshtar finds her Maithili upamana in the figure of Durga or Kali; the Lebanese cedar forest finds its upamana in the sacred groves of Maithili folk religion.

### 6.5 Shabda Pramana and the Status of Literary Translation

The fourth pramana, Shabda (verbal testimony), concerns knowledge derived from the authoritative utterance of a reliable speaker (apta-vakya). Gangesa analyses Shabda with great care, asking what makes a speaker reliable (apta) and how linguistic meaning is generated. The Navya Nyaya school developed a sophisticated philosophy of language, analysing meaning through the categories of shakti (primary semantic relation), lakshana (secondary/metaphorical meaning), and vyanjana (suggestive meaning) — which maps directly onto the Anandavardhana dhvani theory discussed above.

Applied to literary translation: if Gibran's text constitutes an "apta-vakya" — an authoritative utterance — for Arabic readers, Jha's translation seeks to create a secondary apta-vakya in Maithili. The validity of this secondary testimony depends on the translator's reliability as an intermediary — his competence in both source and target languages, his cultural knowledge, and his literary sensibility. The preface of Tutal Pankhi implicitly argues for Jha's reliability through the acknowledgment of scholarly collaboration (Prof. Dr. Bheemnath Jha) and the evidence of careful engagement with Gibran scholarship.

## VII. THE VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY FRAMEWORK

### 7.1 What the Parallel History Framework Proposes

Gajendra Thakur's A Parallel History of Mithila and Maithili Literature (available at www.videha.co.in/gajenthakur.htm, currently running to over 47 parts) articulates a critical framework that positions Maithili literary history not as a regional sub-discipline of Hindi or Indian literary studies but as a tradition with its own internal coherence, its own periodisation, and its own developmental logic — running "parallel" to (not subordinate to) the dominant traditions of Sanskrit, Hindi, and English literature in the Indian context.

Key features of the Parallel History Framework include:

- Historical continuity: Tracing Maithili literature from the Charyapada (9th–11th centuries), through Jyotirishwar Thakur's Varnaratnakar (c. 1300 CE), Vidyapati (c. 1350–1448), the medieval and modern periods, to contemporary digital publishing.
- Epistemological grounding in Mithila's philosophical heritage: Explicit engagement with Gangesa's Navya Nyaya (Parts 16–20 of the Parallel History are dedicated to Gangesa Upadhyaya).
- Attention to diaspora voices: Recognition that Maithili literature is produced not only in Bihar-Nepal but by Maithili speakers across India and internationally.
- Gender-conscious reading: The Parallel History includes the Stri Kona (Women's Corner) section of Videha and explicitly theorises women's voices in Maithili literary history.
- Translation as parallel creation: The framework valorises translation as creative work of equal dignity to original composition, recognising that Maithili culture has always been at the crossroads of Sanskrit, Bengali, Hindi, and now global literary traditions.

## 7.2 Positioning Jha Within the Parallel History

Within the Videha Parallel History Framework, Kirtinath Jha occupies the intersecting position of the diaspora author-translator. His geographical location (Pondicherry), institutional identity (medical college faculty), and literary production (translation of a Lebanese-American author into Maithili) exemplify what Thakur calls the "Vidheha Movement" — named for the ancient Maithili kingdom of Videha, understood not merely as a geographical entity but as a state of mind: disembodied from narrow regionalism, freed for universal engagement.

The mythological figure of the Videha (literally "without body", a philosophical term for the liberated soul) is deliberately invoked: the Maithili writer who transcends the limitations of region and engages with world literature is performing a kind of videha operation, re-embodying the disembodied in a new linguistic form. Jha's translation of Gibran participates fully in this movement.

Moreover, the Parallel History Framework draws attention to the relationship between Maithili and Arabic literary traditions through the shared experience of Bahai-influenced modernism. Gibran was in contact with the Bahai movement; Mithila had its own contact with reformist spiritual traditions through Kabir and the Bhakti movement. The theological syncretism of both Gibran and the

Maithili Bhakti tradition creates a genuine cultural resonance that Jha's translation exploits.

### 7.3 The Kichu Puran Gapa Kichu Nava Gapa in the Parallel History Context

Kirtinath Jha's short-story collection of 2005 engages the Parallel History Framework at the level of form. The Maithili short story (katha) has been the most extensively developed modern prose genre in Maithili letters. Academic surveys show that the 21st century has seen an explosion of short-story writing, with over one hundred collections published between 2015 and 2020 alone. Jha's 2005 collection predates this explosion but participates in the earlier wave of development that followed the Sahitya Akademi recognition of Maithili (1965) and the gradual institutionalisation of Maithili in universities, competitive examinations, and the digital sphere (through Videha).

The title Kichu Puran Gapa Kichu Nava Gapa ("Some Old Stories, Some New Stories") participates in the Parallel History's insistence on continuity-within-change. "Old stories" (puran gapa) may refer to traditional narrative forms — folk tales, myth-inflected realism — while "new stories" (nava gapa) signals engagement with modern techniques: interiority, psychological analysis, symbolic form. Published sources situate this collection within the modernist wave of Maithili short fiction that incorporated "western techniques" while maintaining Maithili cultural specificity.

## VIII. WESTERN LITERARY FRAMEWORKS

### 8.1 Romanticism and the Gibran Tradition

The Western literary tradition that most directly informs Gibran's Broken Wings is European and American Romanticism, especially in its late 19th- / early 20th-century manifestations. Gibran's affinities with Blake (the "prophet-bard" persona, the attack on institutional religion), Whitman (the long, hymnic sentence, the democratic soul), and Nietzsche (the critique of herd morality, the figure of the superior individual crushed by conventional society) are well documented. Gibran's Romantic framework prioritises:

- The sovereignty of the individual feeling over social convention

- Nature as the moral and spiritual ground of truth
- The artist as prophet and social critic
- Love as the supreme value and the supreme martyr

Kirtinath Jha's translation of Broken Wings into Maithili carries these Romantic values into a tradition that has its own analogous currents. The 19th–20th century Maithili renaissance — responding to colonialism, social reform (anti-caste, anti-child marriage movements), and the Bhakti legacy — created a context in which Gibran's Romanticism could land with recognition rather than bewilderment.

## 8.2 Translation Studies: Eugene Nida and Beyond

Modern translation theory provides the most direct Western analytical tool for evaluating Tutal Pankhi. Eugene Nida's distinction between formal equivalence (source-oriented, preserving surface structures) and dynamic equivalence (receptor-oriented, producing equivalent effect) is foundational. Jha's translation strategy tends toward dynamic equivalence: he prioritises the emotional and cognitive effect on the Maithili reader over mechanical fidelity to Gibran's Arabic (or its English rendering) sentence structures.

Lawrence Venuti's distinction between foreignization (keeping the foreignness of the source text visible, making the reader travel to the text) and domestication (making the text feel native to the reader) is also useful. Jha practises a calibrated foreignization: Beirut remains Beirut, Lebanon remains Lebanon, the Phoenician/Astarte temple is not converted into a Hindu or Muslim sacred space. At the same time, the emotional and moral architecture is domesticated through Maithili vocabulary, idiom, and cultural association.

George Steiner's hermeneutic motion of translation (trust, aggression, incorporation, restitution) is visible in Jha's preface. He approaches Gibran with "trust" (expressed admiration for the original's power); "aggression" (the translator's necessary invasion of the source text's world to extract meaning); "incorporation" (the absorption of Gibran's world into the Maithili linguistic body); and "restitution" (the acknowledgment, through the dedication and preface, that the original remains primary even as the translation stands independently).

## 8.3 Post-Colonial Theory and the Question of World Literature

The movement of a text from Arabic (1912) to English (1957 translation) to Maithili (2016) enacts a post-colonial literary circuit that deserves theorisation.

Gibran wrote Broken Wings as an Arab author under Ottoman colonial rule, critiquing a local theocratic corruption that was in part enabled by the political conditions of Ottoman domination. The English translations that brought him to world fame came through a Euro-American publishing circuit that filtered and in some ways appropriated the text. Jha's Maithili translation does something different: it brings the text from the semi-metropolitan English into a South Asian minority language, reversing the usual direction of literary globalisation.

In Pascale Casanova's terms (The World Republic of Letters, 2004), texts typically flow from smaller literary spaces toward the "Greenwich meridian" of world literature (historically Paris, now Anglo-American). Jha's translation moves against this flow, taking a canonised world author and making him available in a language with a rich but internationally underrecognised literary tradition. This is a post-colonial literary act of considerable significance.

### 8.4 Structuralism and Narrative Analysis

Vladimir Propp's morphology of folk narrative provides a useful structural grid for Broken Wings / Tutal Pankhi. The narrative follows a recognisable sequence: Initial situation (hero in solitude), Call (meeting with Farris Effandi), Departure into love, Complication (bishop's intervention), Ordeal (Selma's forced marriage), Secret meetings (heroes' resistance), False resolution (years of meetings in the temple), Final catastrophe (Selma's death in childbirth), Mourning (hero at grave). This Proppian structure maps directly onto the narrative arc of Tutal Pankhi. The structural predictability of the tragic love narrative, far from undermining the work's power, is part of its emotional effectiveness: the reader's dread of the inevitable outcome intensifies affect throughout.

Aïdan Greimas's actantial model further illuminates the character functions: the Subject (narrator-lover) pursues the Object (love with Selma); the Helpers are Farris Effandi and the natural world; the Opponents are the Bishop and Mansour Bey; the Sender is Love itself (or God); and the Receiver is humanity at large, invited to witness and learn from the tragedy.

## IX. THE MAITHILI SHORT STORY: KICHU PURAN GAPA KICHU NAVA GAPA

## 9.1 The 21st-Century Maithili Short Story Context

The Maithili short story (katha) is, as documented extensively by scholars, the most prolific and diverse genre in modern Maithili literature. A survey of the period 1915–1995 recorded approximately 8,224 Maithili short stories by some 200 authors. The Sahitya Akademi has awarded several Maithili short-story collections in the 21st century: Nirja Renu's Ritambhara (2003), Vibhuti Anand's Kath (2006), Pradeep Bihari's Sarokar (2007), Manmohan Jha's Gangaputra (2009), and others. Kirtinath Jha's 2005 collection participates in this tradition and is explicitly named in academic surveys of the period.

The dominant features of early 21st-century Maithili short fiction identified by critics include: psychological analysis as a near-separate genre; Western technical influences (stream of consciousness, symbolic structure, psychological realism); sustained attention to the Maithili social landscape (caste, gender, economic change); and the tension between tradition and modernity. Jha's collection engages this full range.

## 9.2 Thematic Analysis: Old Stories and New Stories

The structural principle of the collection — "Some Old, Some New" — indicates a deliberate generic heterogeneity. We may infer, based on the title and on the pattern of contemporary Maithili story writing, that the "old stories" are likely: myth-inflected narratives that draw on the reservoir of Maithili folk tale and legend; stories set in the rural Mithila landscape with its rituals, festivals (Madhushravani, Vivah Panchami), and social hierarchies; and narratives in the tradition of Harimohan Jha's social satire and Jivakant's rural realism.

The "new stories" are likely to involve: urban settings (perhaps including Pondicherry, where Jha is based); psychological interiority and introspection; medical and scientific themes (a natural development for a physician-author); and formal experimentation — the kind of stories that "have become melodious like experimental poetry", as one critic described the trend.

The physician's gaze is a distinct authorial position. Medical practice gives a writer privileged access to human vulnerability, to the body in extremis, to the social inequalities that express themselves in patterns of illness and health. One thinks of the tradition of physician-writers in world literature: Anton Chekhov, William Carlos Williams, Mikhail Bulgakov, A. J. Cronin. Jha inherits this position and its associated moral-observational sensibility.

### 9.3 Craft Elements: A Close Reading Lens

We can identify through the collection's historical reception and its author's profile certain likely craft features:

- Character: Likely a range of socially located characters — rural women, urban professionals, patients, priests, politicians — rendered with the precise social observation that Maithili realism demands.
- Setting: Dual settings of Mithila (Bihar/Nepal) and possibly South India (Pondicherry), creating a productive geographic tension.
- Narrative voice: The collection title's modesty ("some old, some new") suggests an author conscious of tradition, not eager to claim revolutionary innovation but quietly experimenting.
- Language: Given the evidence of Tutal Pankhi, Jha's Maithili prose is fluid, grammatically competent, and balanced between literary and colloquial registers.

## X. SYNTHESIS: THE THREE LENSES COMPARED

The three analytical frameworks — Indian classical criticism (rasa-dhvani-alamkara), Navya Nyaya epistemology, and Western literary theory — converge on a set of evaluative conclusions about Kirtinath Jha's work that are broadly consistent, while each framework illuminates different aspects of the literary achievement.

### 10.1 On the Translation (Tutal Pankhi)

The Indian classical framework reads Tutal Pankhi as a successful vipralambha shringara work that activates karuna rasa through the mechanism of dhvani-resonance, achieving the sādhāraṇīkaraṇa (universalisation) of its tragic love narrative. The Navya Nyaya framework reads it as an epistemological act of upamana (comparison), building bridges between two cultural worlds through the identification of shared features (shared human experiences of love, loss, institutional corruption) while respecting the irreducible differences between Arabic/Lebanese and Maithili cultural reality. The Western framework reads it as an instance of ethical foreignization that resists domestication and asks Maithili readers to expand their literary world.

### 10.2 On the Short Story Collection

The Indian framework would read Kichu Puran Gapa Kichu Nava Gapa as a collection that participates in the tradition of alamkara-rich realism while incorporating modern psychological depth. The Navya Nyaya framework draws attention to the epistemological dimension of the title itself: how do we distinguish the “old” from the “new” in narrative? Through vyapti (universal concomitance) or through laksana (contextual meaning)? The Western framework situates the collection within the global post-colonial short story tradition, noting its dual allegiance to local specificity and universal reach.

### 10.3 On the Author’s Position

The Videha Parallel History Framework provides the most comprehensive contextualisation: Kirtinath Jha is a diaspora Maithili author who serves as a cultural bridge between the Mithila intellectual tradition (rooted in Gangesa’s Mithila) and world literary culture (through Gibran’s globalised Arabic text). His location in Pondicherry — a former French colony in South India with a cosmopolitan cultural identity — makes him literally and figuratively a border-dweller, simultaneously inside and outside multiple cultural formations. This border position is precisely the locus from which the most productive literary work can emerge.

## XI. CRITICAL EVALUATION AND ASSESSMENT

### 11.1 Strengths of the Works

Across both works, the following strengths are identifiable:

1. Linguistic competence: Jha’s Maithili is syntactically fluent and lexically rich, drawing on both the Sanskritic stratum and the vernacular.
2. Cultural sensitivity: The translation of Broken Wings demonstrates awareness of both source and target cultural contexts, avoiding the twin failures of over-domestication and incomprehensible foreignness.
3. Historical significance: Tutal Pankhi appears to be the first Maithili translation of Gibran — a landmark act of cultural mediation.
4. Thematic range: The short-story collection’s title signals a willingness to work across the spectrum from tradition to experiment.

5. Scholarly embedding: The preface and acknowledgements of Tutal Pankhi situate the work within a community of Maithili scholarship, resisting the isolation that often afflicts diaspora writers.

### 11.2 Areas for Further Research

The following areas present opportunities for deeper scholarly engagement:

6. A comprehensive analysis of Kichu Puran Gapa Kichu Nava Gapa individual story-level analysis.
7. A systematic comparison of Jha's Tutal Pankhi with existing translations of Broken Wings in other Indian languages (Bengali, Hindi, Marathi) would reveal the specifically Maithili strategies at work.
8. An inquiry into how Jha's medical professional identity shapes his narrative and thematic choices would be productive.
9. Oral reception: How has Tutal Pankhi been received in Maithili reading communities in Bihar, Jharkhand, and the Maithili diaspora?

## XII. CONCLUSION

Dr. Kirtinath Jha's literary contribution to Maithili letters is best understood as a form of cultural diplomacy performed through literary form. His short-story collection Kichu Puran Gapa Kichu Nava Gapa (2005) plants one foot in Maithili tradition and the other in modern narrative experimentation; his translation Tutal Pankhi (2016) carries the Maithili literary imagination into conversation with one of the 20th century's most beloved world authors.

Analysed through the convergent lenses of Indian classical aesthetics (rasa-dhvani-alamkara), Navya Nyaya epistemology (the pramana framework of Gangesa Upadhyaya), the Videha Parallel History Framework (with its insistence on Maithili's parallel, not subordinate, literary history), and Western literary theories (Romanticism, Translation Studies, Post-colonialism, Structuralism), Jha's works emerge as modest in self-presentation but significant in cultural impact.

The fact that Gangesa Upadhyaya — the intellectual founder of Navya Nyaya — was born and worked in the Mithila region, and that Printvell Press of Darbhanga (the heart of Mithila) published Jha's translation, creates a poetically resonant historical continuity: the land that produced the most rigorous epistemological tradition in classical India now produces literature

that applies that tradition's precision of observation to the global literary conversation. Kirtinath Jha participates, humbly and effectively, in this living tradition.

In the words that Jha translates from Gibran's Selma — words that could stand as the epigraph for the entire Videha literary project —:

> *"God made woman from the beauty of the East and the wisdom of the West, and now permits them to be destroyed by the ugliness of both." — [Adapted from Tutal Pankhi]*

Kirtinath Jha's literary act is to refuse that destruction — to use the beauty of Maithili and the wisdom of Gibran to create something that is neither purely Eastern nor purely Western, but genuinely human.

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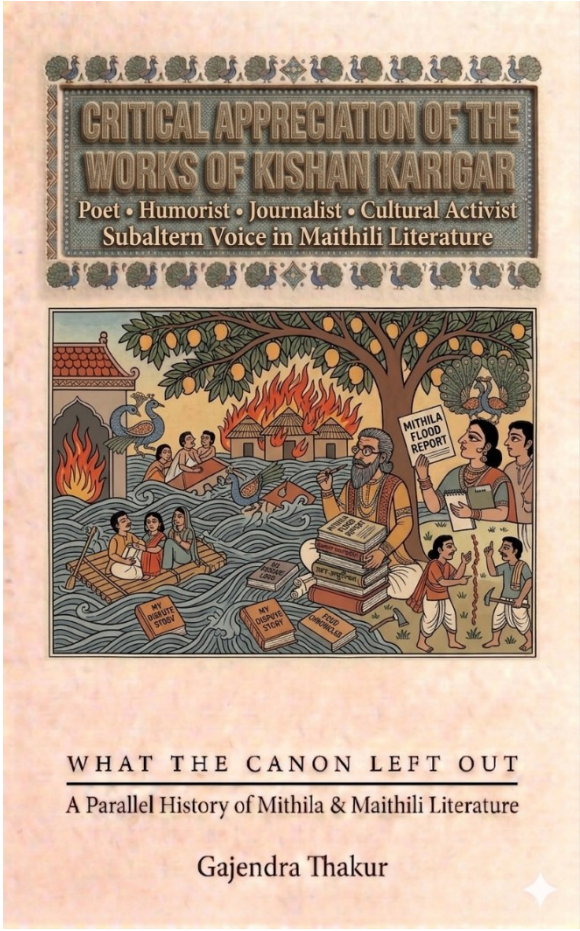
**LESSON 039 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**




# CRITICAL APPRECIATION OF THE WORKS OF

# DR KISHAN KARIGAR

*Poet • Humorist • Journalist • Cultural Activist*

*Subaltern Voice in Maithili Literature*

*Analysed through Indian & Western Literary Theory*

*Videha Parallel History Framework • Navya-Nyāya Epistemology*

## I. BIOGRAPHICAL OVERVIEW

Kishan Karigar — whose given name is Dr. Krishna Kumar Ray (Devanagari: कृष्ण कुमार राय) — was born on 5 March 1983 in Calcutta, into a family rooted in the Mithila region of northern Bihar. His father, Shri Sitanand Ray (‘Nandu’), and mother, Shrimati Anupama Devi, provided a domestic environment marked by the oral traditions of Maithili speech and song. His paternal grandfather, the late Ram Avatar Ray (Master Saheb), is acknowledged by Karigar himself in the dedication of his debut collection as the first teacher who initiated him into Maithili letters.

Karigar’s intellectual formation was as a student of science, yet the lure of literature emerged early. He began writing short pieces, and some of his compositions were broadcast on All India Radio programmes — including the Vividh Bharati show for children, ‘Tum Jiyo Hazaron Saal’, for which he received a consolation prize at the age of roughly fifteen or sixteen, a formative episode narrated with characteristic self-deprecating humour in the preface (‘Appan Baat’) to his debut volume. Regular Maithili composition began in earnest after he completed his intermediate examination in 2009, and his poems were broadcast on the Kantipur FM programme ‘Hello Mithila’, encouraging further commitment to the language.

In 2005, renouncing employment with the Indian Railways, Karigar relocated from Calcutta to Delhi to study journalism. This decisive move repositioned him as a Delhi-based Maithili literary worker and media professional. He has worked as journalist and editor with print and electronic organisations including Amar Bharati, Punjab Kesari, Real Vach, Hamar TV, Channel 1, TV 100, Akashvani, and Doordarshan. He is presently a part-time correspondent for Akashvani Delhi, and — crucially for the Videha Parallel History Framework — the founder-editor of the Maithili periodical ‘Mithilanchal

Today' and the Hindi newspaper 'Authentic Idea.' His principal literary work to date is the Maithili poetry collection 'Kichhu Fura Gel Hamra' (Mithilanchal Today Prakashan, New Delhi, first edition 2014), preface by Dr. Shafalika Verma (Delhi, Vijaya-dashami, 24 October 2013).

Karigar's pen-name encodes a programme: 'Karigar' (craftsman, artisan) signals identification with the world of physical labour and trade rather than the Brahminical or Kayastha cultural elite that has historically dominated Maithili literary production and its institutions. This nominal act of self-positioning is itself a statement within the field of Maithili identity politics.

## II. THE VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY FRAMEWORK: SITUATING KARIGAR

The Videha Parallel History of Mithila and Maithili Literature, initiated and edited by Gajendra Thakur, proceeds from the thesis that the received canon of Maithili literature — institutionalised through the Sahitya Akademi award system, the Mithila Darshan network, and the publication ecology of Darbhanga and Patna — has systematically suppressed or marginalised voices that did not conform to the linguistic, caste, and ideological norms of what Karigar himself describes (in his Sahityapedia essay 'Mechanism of Maithili Literature') as the Brahman-Kayastha standard ('maanak'). The framework insists that the full literary history of Mithila must include the subaltern, Dalit, diaspora, and counter-canonical voices who wrote, published, and circulated outside the dominant institutions.

Kishan Karigar fits squarely within the Videha Parallel History's scope of concern. His background is from the Yadav/Ray community rather than the Maithil Brahman or Kayastha elite. His literary debut was through Mithilanchal Today Prakashan rather than one of the establishment Maithili publishers. The foreword to his volume was written by Dr. Shafalika Verma, a Hindi scholar and critic rather than a Maithili Academy insider — a further mark of institutional distance. His poetry addresses social and political subjects — caste division, corruption, dowry violence, unemployment, urban alienation, political chicanery — that are structurally excluded from the lyric and classical idioms privileged by the canon.

Critically, Karigar's essay 'Mechanism of Maithili Literature' enunciates a polemic consistent with the Videha framework: the demand that all castes and

communities of Mithila — whose blood, he writes, is equally red (‘Sabahak dehak khoon ek rang laal achhi’) — be treated as Maithil and that no caste’s literary dialect be stigmatised as ‘low standard.’ His poem ‘Bantwaraa’ (Division / Partition) directly articulates this. The Videha Parallel History framework thus provides the enabling institutional and ideological context for reading Karigar not as a peripheral figure but as a representative voice of a consciously democratic, anti-hierarchical Maithili literary modernity.

# III. TEXTUAL ANALYSIS: KICHHU FURA GEL HAMRA (2014)

## A. Structure and Thematic Architecture

The volume comprises thirty-five poems arranged broadly by mood and register, moving between lyric pathos (poems of personal emotion, family, and nostalgia), political satire (‘haasya kavita’ or comic-satirical verse), and social critique. The title — ‘Kichhu Fura Gel Hamra’, meaning ‘Something Has Been Lost to Us / Something Came to Mind for Me’ (the Maithili verb ‘furaana’ carries both senses) — is semantically double: it invokes both the poet’s act of spontaneous creative impulse and a community’s loss of cultural memory, ethical cohesion, and social justice.

Dr. Shafalika Verma’s preface identifies the collection as ‘a gathering of the emotional current of a particular age,’ and locates its dominant note in the juxtaposition of realist social critique with lyric vulnerability: ‘the realistic tone of each poem creates a stir (hilkor machaait achhi).’ She connects this to the standard literary-sociological observation that literature is the mirror of society, but notes that the collection goes further, asking what structural forces — unemployment, inflation, the fracturing of personal identity — produce the social anguish the poems depict.

## B. Poem-by-Poem Critical Analysis

### *1. Aabi Gel Nav Varsh (The New Year Has Come)*

The opening poem, a festive address to a friend (‘ou bhaai’), establishes the communal and inclusive ethos of the collection. Its refrains of collective celebration — playing the dhol, sharing meals, the new daughter-in-law cooking puri, the grandfather dancing — constitute a pastoral invocation of

Maithili folk culture. The poem's Rasa (dominant emotional flavour in the sense of Bharatamuni's Natyashastra and its elaboration by Abhinavagupta) is predominantly Shringara-Hasya (festive joy), but the closing injunction — 'do something meaningful for our soil and water' ('kichhu saarthak kaaj karaith rahoo') — inserts a note of Vira-rasa (heroic aspiration). From a Navya-Nyaya standpoint, this final injunction functions as a vyapti (pervasive rule) that governs the entire collection: creative expression ('kichhu furaana') must be placed in the service of social transformation.

### *2. Bantwaraa (Division / Partition)*

This is among the most programmatically significant poems in the collection. Its argument, structured as an apostrophe to the people of Mithila, is that caste-based internal division has hollowed out Maithili cultural identity. The poem's pivotal declaration — 'Ham kahi maithilak kono jaati nai / sabh gote ek chhi Mithilak dhruvataara' ('I say there is no caste of Maithil / all are one, the pole-star of Mithila') — is a deliberate rhetorical inversion of the caste hierarchy that historically structured Mithila's social and literary life.

In rasa theory terms, the dominant rasa here is Vira (heroism, but in the civic-ethical sense elaborated by Mammata in Kavyaprakasha), inflected by Karuna (grief, for the lost solidarity). The closing couplet, which images all Maithil blood as equally red, performs what western criticism would call a universalising enthymeme: the suppressed major premise is that biological commonality grounds civic equality. From a Navya-Nyaya perspective, the poem's epistemological move is that of anumana (inference): if all Mithila's people share identical blood (hetu/reason), they share identical cultural citizenship (sadhya/conclusion). The hetu is stated; the paksha and sadhya are rhetorically enacted.

### *3. Bhin Bhinauj (Separate Hearths)*

This poem addresses the domestic tragedy of brothers dividing their household, leaving aged parents to die neglected. It moves between registers of satire and lament. The aged father's tears ('jhar jhar bahi rahal achhi budhbak aankhis') constitute a sustained Karuna-rasa sequence. The irony of modern sons who do not care for living parents but hold lavish feasts after their death ('panch gaam len puri jilebi bhoj kiye karai chhi') is a classic device of vakrokti (oblique expression, elaborated by Kuntaka in Vakroktijivita): the deflection between the stated action (grand feast) and the implied condemnation creates the satiric charge.

From a Freudian perspective (Freud's essay 'Mourning and Melancholia'), the poem stages a social version of melancholia: the object of attachment (joint family, communal care, filial duty) is not merely lost but denied, producing a cultural pathology. From a Marxist-materialist reading, the poem's theme of property division ('bantwaraa') is a symptom of the penetration of capitalist exchange values ('rupaiya ki dheri' — piles of money) into the pre-capitalist affective economy of the Maithili joint family.

### *4. Veer Jawan (The Brave Soldier)*

This patriotic poem, dedicated to martyred Indian soldiers, is written in the Vira-rasa with intermittent Karuna notes (the soldier's sacrifice, the nation's inability to adequately mourn). Its formal features — repetition of the refrain 'Naman karait chhi hum ahaan chhi veer jawan' — constitute an anaphoric structure that in Maithili oral tradition echoes the invocatory repetition of devotional padavali. The poem's politics are mainstream nationalist, positioned within the dominant ideological space of post-independence Indian literary patriotism. Within the Videha Parallel History framework, its interest lies in the democratisation of who is permitted to speak the idiom of patriotism: the poet's subaltern voice claims the right to the national lyric.

### *5. Dahej (Dowry)*

The anti-dowry poem is written in a register that shifts between direct denunciation and dark irony. Its ethical structure draws on what Aristotle would call pathos (appeal to the audience's moral feeling) and ethos (the poet's authoritative voice as a concerned citizen). The poem's social realism is reinforced by the specific detail of 'bariyaati turning back' when the demanded dowry is not met — a recognisable social practice named and exposed.

The feminist theoretical framework of Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak is relevant here: the poem stages the 'subaltern woman' (the bride, the female foetus threatened by selective abortion) as unable to speak in her own right, her fate determined by the patriarchal transaction of dowry. The poem's invocation of the endangered female foetus ('maada bhrun aa nav kaniya') connects it to the legal and activist discourse around female infanticide and sex-selective abortion in northern India. The poem ends with an oath ('khau akhan sapat') — a performative speech act in Austin's sense — inviting the reader to pledge renunciation of dowry demand.

### *6. Desh ki Chinta (Concern for the Nation)*

This satirical poem on political self-interest versus genuine governance is formally a comic enumeration of the various types of politician's 'chinta' (concern): concern for bribery, concern for a ministerial chair, concern for personal advancement — but no concern for the nation. The anaphoric structure ('kinako chhi' repeated) creates cumulative satiric force. In Bharatamuni's rasa-system, this would be classified as Bhibhatsa-rasa (disgust), directed at the political class; in Kuntaka's vakrokti framework, the poem's obliquity consists in attributing 'concerns' to politicians that are precisely the opposite of the civic concerns they publicly profess.

### *7. Daugal Chali Jai Gaam (Let Me Go Back to the Village)*

This lyric of urban alienation is among the collection's most sustained and complex poems. It moves through a series of contrasts: the city's concrete and steel versus the village's thatched roofs; the anonymity of the modern high-rise flat versus the warm recognition of neighbours in the village lane. The poem's dominant rasa is Shringara-Vatsalya (love, affection) inflected by Karuna (grief for what is lost), with the governing figure being the Maithili folk motif of 'gaam' (village) as the site of authentic relationship.

The poem can be read through Raymond Williams' critical framework of 'The Country and the City' (1973): the village is ideologically constructed as the space of community and humanity in contrast to the city as the space of commodity and atomisation. However, unlike Williams' diagnosis, which is suspicious of the nostalgic pastoral, Karigar's poem offers what might be called a subaltern pastoral: the village is not a bourgeois romantic escape but a memory of an actually existing social formation being destroyed by urban migration, a process experienced by millions of Bihari migrant workers in Delhi. The city's alienation is not abstract existential angst but the concrete social condition of the Bihari migrant labourer.

### *8. Ekta Te O Chhalih (She Was the Only One)*

This elegy for a deceased mother is, along with 'Sahanta', the collection's most personally intimate poem. The poem is written as a series of memories of the mother's acts: feeding the child, consoling him, teaching him Maithili through oral tradition, the instruction to be a good person ('naik manukh') rather than merely a koel bird (praised for song alone). The mother's death, and the impossibility of return, is articulated through the device of the persistent hope

that she might yet come home from her father's house — a psychic refusal of finality.

In Freudian terms, the poem is an instance of 'Mourning and Melancholia': the poet cannot complete mourning because the loss of the mother is also the loss of the primary medium of cultural and linguistic transmission (Maithili language itself). The mother's role as teacher of Maithili ('matribhasha') makes her death a figure for threatened linguistic extinction. From the perspective of Rasa theory, the poem is a sustained Karuna-rasa composition, but the rasa is produced not by the spectacle of suffering but by the accumulation of small domestic acts of love — consistent with the Abhinavagupta elaboration of rasa as arising from the spectator's own (sahridaya's) empathetic identification with the vibhava (determinants) and anubhava (consequents) of emotion in the text.

### *9. Galchotaka Var (The Short-Necked Groom) [Satirical Poem]*

This haasya kavita (comic poem) is a bravura piece of social satire on the dowry-inflated marriage market. The 'galchotaka var' (groom with a short neck, a Maithili idiom for a short, unprepossessing man inflated by self-importance) is a walking contradiction: educated but worthless, eating three kilos at one sitting but thin as a bamboo stick, demanding dowry while being himself a poor match. The poem's comic technique is the incongruity-resolution mechanism described in modern humour theory (Raskin's Script-based Semantic Theory of Humour, 1985; Attardo's General Theory of Verbal Humor, 1994): the 'script' of the desirable groom is systematically violated by the 'galchotaka var''s actual attributes, producing comedy. In Maithili tradition, this technique recalls the haasya passages in Vidyapati's padavali and the comic vignettes of Jivanjha's tradition.

### *10. Gareeb (The Poor Man)*

This poem of poverty and social invisibility is one of the collection's most sustained realist compositions. Its catalogue of the poor man's conditions — working all day without eating, wages looted by contractors, no access to healthcare, children crying for food — employs the rhetorical strategy of prosopopoeia (the poor man speaking for himself) combined with an epistrophe (the refrain 'kiye te ham chhi gareeb' — 'for we are poor'). The dominant rasa is Karuna, but inflected by what Bharatamuni calls Raudra (righteous anger), since the poem is not a plea for pity but an indictment.

From the perspective of Dalit criticism (as theorised by, among others, Sharankumar Limbale in 'Towards an Aesthetic of Dalit Literature', 2004), the

poem's significance lies in its first-person voicing of poverty as lived experience rather than as the object of charitable concern. The poor man speaks; he is not spoken for. This is consistent with the Videha Parallel History's insistence on the author's social positioning as constitutive of literary meaning.

### *11. Hakim Bha Galah (He Has Become an Official)*

This poem — about a village man who goes to the city, becomes a bureaucrat or officer, and becomes unrecognisable to his own kin — is a classic example of the 'return to roots' theme in South Asian literature of migration and social mobility. Its central figure is the man who, having achieved status, abandons his aged parents ('buddh maaye baap ke chhodhike asgar'). The poem's critique is directed less at individual moral failure than at the structural values of a society that equates modern status with the abandonment of traditional obligations ('maaye baap ke satkar').

The poem's formal technique is the dramatic monologue: an old man speaks, then a young man's voice interrupts, and the poem ends with a general philosophical statement. This polyphonic structure anticipates what Bakhtin calls dialogism in the novel — applied here to the lyric form. The dominant rasa is Karuna, but the poem's ethical demand is couched in Vira-rasa terms: honouring parents is a form of heroism.

### *12. Hamro Jiib Diya (Give Me My Life Too) [Voice of the Unborn Girl]*

This poem, written in the voice of a female foetus about to be aborted after sex-selective ultrasound, is among the most formally and ethically complex in the collection. Its speaker addresses her father directly, pleading for the right to live. The poem stages a dramatic inversion: the socially silenced voice (the unborn girl) is given speech; the socially empowered voice (the father) is placed in the position of accused.

In Navya-Nyaya epistemological terms, the poem deploys the device of pratijnya (proposition) and its refutation through a counter-example (drshtanta): the argument that a daughter's birth is a crime ('betii bha ke janam lenahi kono aparaadh nai') is itself the counter-proposition that is both stated and refuted. The poem's ethical logic is that the unborn girl's claim to life is a valid anumana (inference) from the paksha that all human beings deserve existence. The hetu (reason) is that she is a human being; the sadhya (conclusion) is that she deserves to live; the vyapti (pervasive concomitance) is that all human beings deserve existence.

From a feminist-theoretical perspective (drawing on Sara Ruddick's maternal thinking and M. Nussbaum's capabilities approach), the poem's significance is that it articulates a right-to-life argument not from a religious standpoint but from the standpoint of the endangered girl's own subjective claim.

### *13. Puraskaar Le Ke Nachoo (Dance for the Award) [Satirical Poem]*

This haasya kavita on the corruption of the Maithili literary award system is the collection's most direct engagement with the institutional politics of Maithili literature. The poem's target is the coterie system ('apan kutum baisal chhi Academy aa chayan board mein' — 'one's own kin sitting on the Academy and selection boards'), the award as social currency rather than recognition of literary merit, and the figure of the 'pisalguaa' (sycophant / toady) who gains recognition through factional loyalty.

In Bourdieu's theory of literary fields ('The Rules of Art', 1992/1996), this poem is a direct critique of the conversion of cultural capital into social capital through the mechanism of the prize. The poem names the specific structural dynamics Bourdieu identifies: the dominant faction within the literary field uses the award system to reproduce its own position. The 'karigar' (craftsman, artisan, the poet's own pen-name) is the figure excluded from this system by virtue of not belonging to the dominant faction.

The poem's self-referential dimension — the poet speaking in his own pen-name ('ahaan jo likhalo karigar') — is a moment of ironic self-distancing: even the poet's own work, he suggests, would not win an award in the current system. This is consistent with the Videha Parallel History's founding thesis that the award system has actively suppressed parallel voices.

### *14. Panda Aa Dalaal (The Priest-Broker and the Middleman) [Satirical Poem]*

This poem extends the institutional critique to the broader cultural field of Maithili literary organisation. The 'panda' (priestly broker at pilgrimage sites, used here metaphorically for the cultural gatekeeper) and the 'dalal' (middleman, commission agent) are identified as two functionally equivalent types who between them control access to literary recognition, publication, and platform. The poem's targets are coterie formation, factionalism, and the suppression of genuine creative work in favour of cultural patronage networks.

This poem is among the most explicit articulations in the collection of the politics identified by the Videha Parallel History Framework. Its diagnostic force depends on the reader's recognition of the specific institutional landscape

of Maithili literary culture — the academies in Patna and Darbhanga, the literary organisations in Delhi, the coteries that control publication and prize nomination. The poem's vocabulary of 'tikadhambaji' (factional plotting) and 'khamebazi' (coalition-mongering) is drawn from the specific discourse of Maithili literary politics.

### *15. Manukh Banab Kona? (How to Become a Human Being?)*

The collection's penultimate section contains this meditation on caste prejudice and the possibility of ethical community in Mithila. The poem begins with the exclamation of disgust at untouchability and caste-based social exclusion ('Chhih chhih dhoor chhih'), and proceeds to argue that all people of Mithila, regardless of caste, are children of the same mother ('Mithila ke Maithil'). Its conclusion — the invocation to all to take an oath that they will treat each other as equals — is the collection's most explicit statement of Ambedkarite social ethics translated into Maithili lyric form.

In the context of Dalit literary aesthetics as theorised by Limbale, the poem represents a significant moment: it is written not by a Dalit author (Karigar's own social position is within the Other Backward Classes community) but in solidarity with the Ambedkarite principle of caste abolition. This solidarity across caste lines is itself a political act, consistent with the Videha Parallel History Framework's inclusion of subaltern and allied voices.

## IV. NAVYA-NYĀYA EPISTEMOLOGICAL ANALYSIS

### A. The Framework of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (c. 1320 CE), the founder of Navya-Nyaya and author of the Tattvacintāmaṇi, was himself a Maithili Brahman from Mithila — a historical fact that creates a productive tension when his epistemological framework is applied to Kishan Karigar, a poet who explicitly challenges the cultural dominance of the Maithili Brahman establishment. This tension is itself philosophically productive: it demonstrates that the tools of Maithili intellectual heritage are available to all, not only to those within the dominant tradition.

Navya-Nyaya epistemology is distinguished by its rigorous analysis of the structure of cognition, the conditions of valid inference (anumana), and the

linguistic encoding of knowledge-claims. The Tattvacintāmaṇi's Pratyakṣa-khaṇḍa (section on perception) argues that perceptual knowledge involves not merely the reception of sensory data but the cognitive construction of the object through a process of vyapyavritti (pervaded occurrence) — a concept with direct relevance to how literary texts encode worldviews.

## B. Applying Navya-Nyaya Categories to Karigar's Poetry

In Navya-Nyaya logic, a valid cognition (prama) is distinguished from a pseudo-cognition (aprama) by its conformity to the actual state of affairs (yatharthanubhava). Karigar's poetry consistently claims the status of prama: it presents social suffering (poverty, dowry violence, unemployment, caste discrimination) as direct, unmediated experience rather than literary convention. The poems' 'I' figure claims perceptual authority ('ham dekhait chhi' — 'I see') over the social conditions it describes.

The structure of Navya-Nyaya inference (anumana) consists of five members: paksha (the subject), sadhya (the property to be proved), hetu (the reason), drshtanta (the example), and upanaya (the application). Many of Karigar's satirical poems implicitly follow this structure. In 'Bantwaraa', for example: paksha = Maithil society; sadhya = self-destructive fragmentation; hetu = caste-based division; drshtanta = the fact that all Maithil blood is identical; upanaya = therefore, Maithil society is committing self-harm through its internal divisions.

Navya-Nyaya also develops the concept of upAdhi (limiting condition or defeater): a condition that, if present, invalidates the inference. Karigar's poetry systematically identifies the upAdhi of Maithili social discourse: caste hierarchy, which falsely presents division as natural rather than constructed, and thereby invalidates arguments for social solidarity. By exposing this upAdhi, the poetry claims to restore the validity of the inference — all Maithil are one — that the upAdhi has been suppressing.

Gaṅgeśa's analysis of śabda (verbal testimony) as a source of valid cognition is also directly relevant to Karigar's project. For Navya-Nyaya, the validity of verbal testimony depends on the speaker's aptata (competence, trustworthiness). Karigar's consistent self-positioning as a subaltern voice — someone who speaks from within and for the oppressed communities of Mithila — is an implicit claim to aptata in this sense: he is competent to report on the social conditions he describes because he has lived and experienced them.

# V. RASA, DHVANI, AND VAKROKTI: INDIAN LITERARY THEORY

## A. Rasa Analysis (Bharatamuni, Abhinavagupta)

Bharatamuni's Natyashastra (c. 2nd c. BCE – 3rd c. CE) identifies eight primary rasas: Shringara (love), Hasya (comedy), Karuna (sorrow), Raudra (fury), Vira (heroism), Bhayanaka (terror), Bibhatsa (disgust), and Adbhuta (wonder). Abhinavagupta's commentary Abhinavabharati (c. 1000 CE) adds Shanta (tranquillity) as a ninth. In Karigar's collection, the dominant rasas are Karuna (the poems of loss, poverty, family grief), Hasya-Bibhatsa (the satirical poems, which use comedy to induce disgust at social corruption), and Vira (the poems of solidarity, social activism, and anti-caste assertion).

Abhinavagupta's theory of rasa as an impersonal aesthetic experience (ananda, bliss) that transcends the individual emotions of the poet or reader is tested by Karigar's explicitly political poetry: can the rasa theory accommodate poems that are designed to produce not aesthetic bliss but civic action? The answer, within the tradition, is yes: Vira-rasa as the basis for heroic and ethical action is a well-established category, and the tradition's understanding that the sahridaya (sensitive reader) participates in the text's emotional world through their own accumulated social experience supports the reading of politically engaged poetry as rasa-productive.

## B. Dhvani Theory (Anandavardhana)

Anandavardhana's Dhvanyaloka (c. 9th c. CE) argues that the highest literary quality is dhvani or suggestion: the resonance of meaning beyond what is explicitly stated. In Karigar's satirical poems, dhvani functions as the engine of irony. When 'Puraskaar Le Ke Nachoo' addresses the sycophant's advice to 'go and dance for the award,' the vachyartha (stated meaning) is a sardonic invitation; the lakshyartha (secondary meaning) is a critique of the award system; and the vyangya (dhvani) is the poem's implied claim that literary value cannot be reduced to institutional recognition. This three-level structure of meaning is precisely what Anandavardhana theorises as the mark of genuine kavya (poetry).

## C. Vakrokti (Kuntaka)

Kuntaka's Vakroktijivita (c. 10th c. CE) proposes that the defining quality of poetry is vakrokti — oblique, turned, or twisted expression — by which the

poet achieves a stylistic ‘strangeness’ that defamiliarises ordinary language and makes the familiar new. In Karigar’s haasya kavita, vakrokti operates through incongruity, ironic reversal, and the mining of folk idiom for unexpected poetic force. The phrase ‘galchotaka var’ (the short-necked groom), for example, works as vakrokti by converting a physical descriptor into a social and moral characterisation.

## VI. WESTERN LITERARY-CRITICAL FRAMEWORKS

### A. Marxist and Materialist Criticism

From a Marxist standpoint, Karigar’s poetry can be read as literature of a specific socio-economic formation: the experience of the north Indian urban migrant from a subaltern caste background, occupying the precarious positions of journalist, part-time broadcaster, and small-scale publisher in the informal economy of Delhi. His poems consistently encode the experience of economic precarity — the ‘gareeb’ (poor man), the unemployed youth, the contracted worker whose wages are stolen by the ‘thekedaar’ (contractor).

Georg Lukacs’ theory of realism (‘The Historical Novel’, 1937; ‘Studies in European Realism’, 1950) distinguishes between naturalist description of surface phenomena and realist apprehension of the underlying structural forces that produce those phenomena. Karigar’s stronger poems achieve Lukacsian realism: they do not merely describe poverty but articulate its structural causes (contractor exploitation, inflation, corrupt governance). His weaker poems remain at the level of naturalist complaint.

### B. Postcolonial and Subaltern Studies

Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak’s foundational question ‘Can the Subaltern Speak?’ (1988) is directly relevant to Karigar’s project. His poetry insists on the subaltern’s speech: the ‘gareeb’, the female foetus, the aged parent, the unemployed youth all speak in the first person or are given direct voice. However, Spivak’s point is not simply that the subaltern cannot speak, but that the conditions of speaking — including the institutional channels through which speech becomes audible — are themselves structured by power. Karigar’s position as a small-publisher poet outside the Sahitya Akademi system illustrates exactly this: his poems exist and circulate, but within a

restricted field of reception, precisely because the dominant institutions have not legitimated them.

The Videha Parallel History Framework can be read as a systematic attempt to create the conditions under which the subaltern's speech becomes audible: by archiving, contextualising, and critically evaluating the parallel literary tradition, Videha performs what Homi Bhabha ('The Location of Culture', 1994) calls 'third space' enunciation — a space of cultural negotiation that is neither the dominant canon nor its simple negation, but a new field of meaning-production.

## C. Bakhtin and Heteroglossia

Mikhail Bakhtin's concept of heteroglossia (the coexistence of multiple social speech-types within a single utterance or text) is highly productive for reading Karigar's poetry. His poems consistently mix registers: the formal diction of literary Maithili, the everyday speech of Mithila villages, the political rhetoric of newspaper editorials, and the folk idiom of Maithili oral tradition. This mixing is not stylistic failure but ideological assertion: it refuses the hierarchical purism that insists on 'standard' literary Maithili as the only legitimate medium.

Bakhtin's concept of the carnivalesque ('Rabelais and His World', 1965/1984) is also relevant to the haasya kavita: the comic inversion of social hierarchies in poems like 'Galchotaka Var' and 'Mukhiya Ji Dethihin' performs a temporary symbolic reversal of the social order, in which the powerful are made ridiculous and the ordinary person is accorded dignity.

## D. Bourdieu's Field Theory

Pierre Bourdieu's theory of the literary field, as elaborated in 'The Rules of Art' (1992) and 'The Field of Cultural Production' (1993), provides the most precise sociological framework for Karigar's institutional position. The Maithili literary field is characterised by a dominant fraction (Maithil Brahman and Kayastha writers with access to the Sahitya Akademi system) and a dominated fraction (subaltern, Dalit, and diaspora writers without such access). The award system functions as the primary mechanism for the conversion of cultural capital into social and economic capital within the field.

Karigar's pen-name 'Karigar' (craftsman) is a Bourdieusian act of symbolic capital-claiming: it refuses the dominant field's criteria for legitimate cultural authority (high-caste identity, academic credentials, establishment publication)

and proposes an alternative criterion (the craftsman's skill, honesty of labour, social commitment). His poem 'Puraskaar Le Ke Nachoo' is a direct critique of the award system's function as a mechanism for reproducing the dominant fraction's power.

### E. Feminist Theory

Several of Karigar's poems address the condition of women in Maithili society with a directness unusual in the tradition's canonical poetry. 'Dahej' (Dowry), 'Hamro Jiib Diya' (Give Me My Life Too), and 'Enna Kiyak Ee Ki' (Why Is This So?) address dowry violence, female infanticide, and the educational discrimination against daughters respectively. These poems are consistent with what Adrienne Rich calls the 'politics of location' — the insistence that gender inequality is not a matter of individual prejudice but of structural social conditions that can and must be named and challenged.

The poem 'Enna Kiyak Ee Ki' is particularly notable in this context: it directly names the hypocrisy of families that send sons to engineering college and daughters to cook, and ends with an appeal to educate daughters alongside sons. This is consistent with the agenda of the women's education movement in Bihar and the wider south Asian feminist tradition of linking female education with social emancipation.

## VII. THE MAITHILI SUBALTERN VOICE: THEMATIC SYNTHESIS

### A. Language as Political Act

In the Maithili literary context, the choice of language for literary expression has always been politically charged. The classical tradition privileged Sanskrit; the medieval tradition produced the great Maithili literary flowering from Vidyapati onward, but within the constraints of courtly patronage and Brahminical cultural authority. The modern period saw Maithili's struggle for official recognition (achieved in 2003, when Maithili was added to the Eighth Schedule of the Indian Constitution), a struggle in which the definition of 'standard' Maithili has been an instrument of caste power.

Karigar's choice to write in Maithili — against the gravitational pull of Hindi, which offers a vastly larger readership and a more professionalisable literary

career — is a political act of cultural commitment. His use of everyday, non-‘standard’ Maithili vocabulary and idiom (the ‘Solḥkan’/‘Raad’ dialect, associated with the lower and backward castes) is a further political act: it claims the legitimacy of these dialects as literary media.

## B. The Dual Register: Lyric and Satirical

One of the most significant structural features of Karigar’s poetry is the systematic juxtaposition of lyric (karuna, shringara) and satirical (hasya, bibhatsa) registers within a single collection. This juxtaposition is not accidental: it enacts the poet’s thesis that personal grief and social critique are two aspects of the same experience. The poor man’s suffering is simultaneously a private tragedy and a public indictment; the mother’s death is simultaneously a personal loss and a figure for the cultural loss of Maithili language and tradition.

This dual register has precedents in the Maithili tradition: Vidyapati’s verse moves between the devotional (bhakti) and the erotic (shringara), and between celebration and elegy. But Karigar’s use of it is distinctively modern in its politicisation: the satirical poems are not mere comedy but are weapons of social critique, and the lyric poems are not mere sentiment but are arguments for social solidarity.

## C. The Role of Humour

The haasya kavita (comic poem) is one of Karigar’s most distinctive contributions to contemporary Maithili literature. His particular form of comedy — combining folk idiom, political satire, and social critique — draws on the Maithili tradition of haasya (comedy) as a literary and performative mode while adapting it to the conditions of contemporary Indian political life: the neta (politician) as con-artist, the academy as a patronage machine, the ‘panda-dalal’ as the cultural establishment’s enforcer.

The preface by Dr. Shafalika Verma notes this with precision: ‘The poet Karigar’s creative spirit has a vikshoobh (turbulence, agitation) filled with outrage.’ This vikshoobh is the emotional and intellectual matrix from which both the lyric and the satirical poems emerge. It is the mark of what Gramsci called the ‘organic intellectual’ of a subaltern community: someone who combines intellectual work with organic connection to and commitment to their community’s interests.

## VIII. KARIGAR AND THE CONTEMPORARY MAITHILI PARALLEL LITERARY MOVEMENT

Kishan Karigar's work is best understood within the broader context of the Videha Parallel Literary Movement — a term designating the cluster of writers, editors, and cultural workers associated with Videha eJournal and its related publications who are committed to a democratic, anti-canonical, subaltern-inclusive vision of Maithili literature. This movement includes figures as diverse as the ghazal poet Ashish Anchinhar (whose revival of the Maithili ghazal has been documented in the Videha Parallel History, Parts 4-5), the social realist novelist Subhash Chandra Yadav (Parts 35-36), and the satirist Sushil (Part 36), among many others.

Within this movement, Karigar occupies the specific position of the poet-journalist: someone who moves between creative literary work and the daily practice of journalism, and whose poetry bears the marks of this dual vocation. The poems' topicality — their engagement with specific political events (Anna Hazare's Ramlila Maidan movement against corruption, referenced in 'Kariika Rupaiya'; the political manoeuvring of coalition governments, referenced in 'Kathputali Sarkar') — reflects the journalist's habit of engagement with the present moment.

At the same time, the collection's lyric poems of personal and familial emotion ('Ekta Te O Chhalih', 'Sahanta', 'Nabkaniya', 'Doodhpiba Nana') demonstrate a poet who has moved beyond topicality to an engagement with the universal structures of human experience: love, loss, family, community. This movement between the topical and the universal is, within the Videha Parallel History Framework, the mark of a writer who has achieved the transition from protest writing to literature — from the hasya of immediate political critique to the kavya of enduring creative achievement.

# IX. ASSESSMENT: STRENGTHS, LIMITATIONS, AND SIGNIFICANCE

## A. Strengths

The collection's principal strengths are: (1) its consistency of social commitment, which gives the poems a thematic coherence unusual in debut collections; (2) its mastery of the haasya kavita form, in which Karigar demonstrates a genuine command of comic timing, incongruity, and ironic reversal; (3) its engagement with the specific institutional and social conditions of Maithili cultural life, which gives the political poems a particularity and specificity that mere generalist social critique lacks; (4) its lyric moments, which demonstrate that Karigar is capable of genuine emotional depth; and (5) its language, which resists the standardisation of 'sahitya maithili' in favour of a living, heteroglossic idiom.

## B. Limitations

The collection's limitations include: (1) uneven quality, with some poems (particularly the purely topical satirical pieces) being primarily journalistic rather than literary in their achievement; (2) occasional reliance on a protest rhetoric that can slide into didacticism at the expense of aesthetic complexity; (3) the relative underdevelopment of formally experimental modes — the collection works primarily within familiar verse forms rather than seeking new formal possibilities; and (4) the limited engagement with the specifically feminine or Dalit voice — poems about women's condition are written from a sympathetic male standpoint rather than from within the women's experience itself.

## C. Significance

Notwithstanding these limitations, 'Kichhu Fura Gel Hamra' is a significant work in the history of contemporary Maithili literature, for the following reasons: It is among the first collections of Maithili poetry to address, comprehensively and from a subaltern perspective, the full range of social and political conditions of contemporary Mithila: caste hierarchy, dowry violence, political corruption, urban migration, and the institutional politics of the literary field. It demonstrates the vitality of the haasya kavita tradition in the context of contemporary social and political critique. Its author's pen-name enacts a democratic redefinition of who counts as a Maithil literary voice. And its

publication through an independent Maithili press (Mithilanchal Today Prakashan) demonstrates the existence and agency of a publishing infrastructure outside the dominant Sahitya Akademi-connected circuit.

Within the Videha Parallel History Framework, Karigar represents the paradigmatic case of what that framework is designed to document and make visible: a talented, committed literary worker whose work has been marginalised not by its lack of quality but by its non-conformity to the social and institutional norms of the dominant Maithili literary establishment. The task of parallel literary history is to restore such works and such voices to their proper place within the full, democratic account of Maithili literature.

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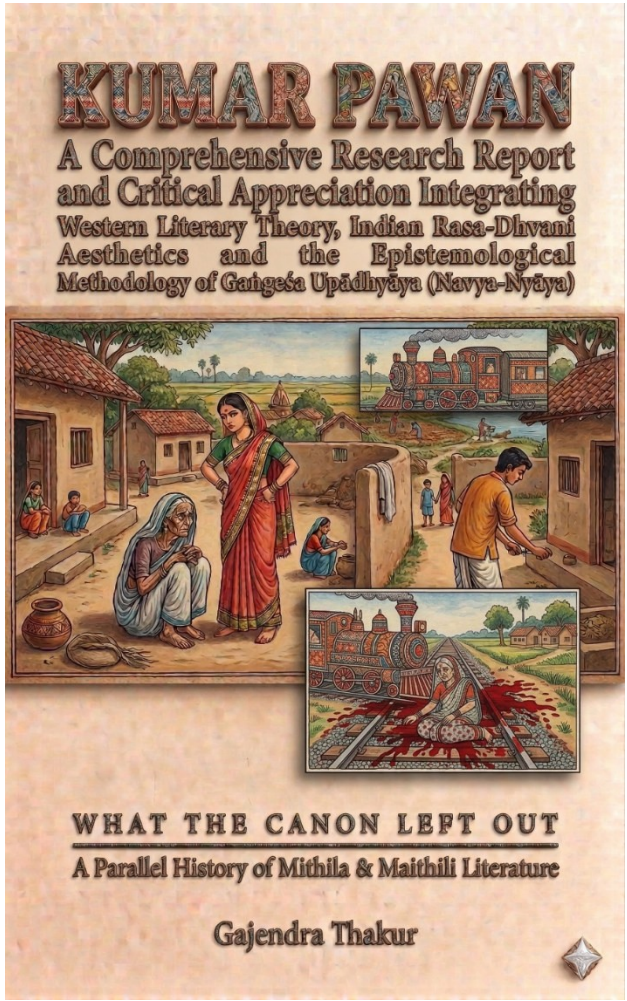
**LESSON 040 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**




# KUMAR PAWAN

*A Comprehensive Research Report and Critical Appreciation*

Integrating Western Literary Theory, Indian Rasa-Dhvani Aesthetics and the Epistemological Methodology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (Navya-Nyāya)

**Texts Examined:**

*“Daayrīk Khālī Pannā” (डायरीक खाली पन्ना) - Story (Dīrgha-kathā)*

*“Paiṭh” (पइठ) - Story (Dīrgha-kathā)*

*"Naih Bisaraicha" & "Kāli tañ Ravi Chhai" - Two Poems*

**ADDENDUM-Asharfi Ke Looti Aa Koilapar Chhaap**

## 1. Introduction: The Writer and His Moment

**Kumar Pawan** is the pen name of **Dr. Pawan Kumar Jha** (born 27 December 1958), a Maithili fiction writer, satirist, and poet who began his literary career in the 1990s but rose to sustained prominence with a second phase of writing from 2008 onwards. A native of Muraiṭhā village, Khaṭaulia, Kamaṭaul, Darbhanga district, Bihar (Pin 847304), he serves as a PGT (Post Graduate Teacher) in Hindi at Kendriya Vidyalaya, Katihar (Bihar). His biography as a government school teacher in provincial Bihar is not incidental to his work - it is its subject matter.

The editorial note in Antika (April–June 2008) describes him as a well-known Maithili poet, storyteller and satirist whose shorter fiction and poems had established a distinct voice; his new phase of writing - beginning again after a decade of literary silence - arrives with a novel long story (dīrgha-kathā) and five poems. The note credits him with establishing "a distinct poet-storyteller identity in Maithili through a few stories and three to four dozen poems." The three texts examined in this report - two long stories and two poems - all first published in Antika or Videha Sadeh between 2008 and 2010 - represent this mature second phase.

The four works examined in this report offer a panorama of provincial Bihar's bureaucratic, educational, and social life, rendered with satirical precision, structural complexity, and a rare combination of compassion and irony. Read together, they constitute a significant contribution to the Maithili parallel literary tradition championed by Videha.

## 2. Summary and Textual Analysis of the Stories

## 2.1 "Dāyrīk Khālī Pannā" (डायरीक खाली पन्ना) - The Empty Pages of the Diary

### *2.1.1 Publication and Form*

Published in *Antika* (October–December 2008, pp. 17–30), classified as *dīrgha-kathā* (long story / novelette), with illustrations by the artist credited within the publication. The story runs to fourteen densely printed double-column pages and is notable for its sectional architecture, with named chapter-like divisions including: *"Nāle me Bajbajāit Pillu"* (The stinking cat in the drain), *"Karmenedācaryek Duḥkh"* (Sorrow of the karma-servant), *"Seṛā Gel Jvālāmukhī"* (The volcano has broken out), *"Kārak Tattva Khoj me Ṭoiyā"* (Searching for the causal principle), *"Vidyāmandir me Kondom"* (Condom in the Temple of Learning), *"Amīr Balban ke Pratāp"* (The power of wealthy Balban), *"Ṭhīk Chhai"* (All right), and *"Ḍāyrīk Pannā par Ke"* (On the pages of the diary).

### *2.1.2 Narrative Summary*

The story's protagonist is an unnamed school principal in a provincial Bihar college - a man of conscience, literary sensibility, and personal integrity who maintains a meticulous diary of his inner life and observations. The story opens with the image of the principal returning home tired from college and sitting in his lawn, reaching for a priceless diary on the central table - but the diary's pages are empty, the pen uncapped beside it. Why has the principal stopped writing? This is the central mystery around which the narrative unfolds.

The story rapidly expands outward from this private interior to the full social environment of the college and town. The principal is surrounded by *Ballī Bābū* - a cunning, ambitious, politically connected colleague whose real name is Murali Krishna Thakur, described as a shape-shifting opportunist who sees the college as a private fiefdom. Ballī Bābū uses every instrument of institutional corruption available: coaching centre rackets, examination fraud, political patronage, police contacts, and ultimately the co-option of a state legislator (MLA) from the Bhavnath Rai faction of the ruling party. He builds his "empire" on the ruins of the principal's integrity.

The cast of secondary characters is drawn with Dickensian precision: *Baḷī Bābū*'s network of student spies; the secretary *Mahōday* who reports everything to two masters simultaneously; the Vivekānanda–Jñāneshvara faction of progressive students; the idealistic poet-professor Pt. Narendra Pathak; the visiting *Kulapati* (Vice-Chancellor) who arrives with his own political agenda

and is caught in an absurd sequence involving a mysterious box of condoms found in the "Temple of Learning" (Vidyāmandir) - a scene that is simultaneously farcical and devastating in its satire of India's state-sponsored religious-moral infrastructure. The figure of *Uṣhā Jī* - a senior female administrator whose dignity, competence and moral clarity set her apart from everyone around her - provides a counter-point of genuine human worth against which the corruption is measured.

The narrative climax comes when the principal, driven to the edge of breakdown by the impossible ethical demands of his position, finally snaps. After an hallucinatory sequence in which his body and face become monstrously disfigured in a vision, he drives blindly into the night, nearly running over Vrindavan Bābu and Uṣhā Jī, stops the car at a railway crossing, and sits motionless. The story ends with the image of the diary's double blank pages spread open under a lamp - the principal's face reflected in them, unconscious.

### *2.1.3 Thematic Architecture*

**The Diary as Epistemological Device:** The story's central formal conceit is that the diary - an instrument of self-knowledge, of recording the *anubhava* (experienced cognition) of daily life - has been rendered blank by the excess of corrupt input. This is both a plot device and a philosophical statement: when the gap between what one perceives and what one is allowed to know becomes unbridgeable, writing becomes impossible. The principal's diary is a direct echo of Gaṅgeśa's concept of *jñāna* (valid knowledge) - specifically the crisis that arises when *pramāṇa* (means of valid cognition) fails, or when anubhava is produced by corrupt sources.

**Satire as Social pramāṇa:** Kumar Pawan's satirical mode in this story operates as a form of *anumāna* (inference) - presenting the visible behaviour of characters (their *vyāpti*, or pervasive connection between sign and signified) to allow the reader to infer the hidden structural forces of corruption. Ballī Bābū's every seemingly trivial act - the way he receives a phone call, the way he places a chair - carries the inferential mark (*liṅga*) of deep institutional corruption.

**The Question of "Amīr Balban":** The section titled "Amīr Balban ke Pratāp" introduces the political-historical analogy of the medieval Slave Dynasty's Balban - a low-born stable-keeper who became Sultan of Delhi through ruthlessness and political cunning. The comparison is used to frame Ballī Bābū's social ascent as a species of counter-historical violence: the institutions of modern India (the college, the examination system, the electoral process)

function as the new court of Balban, where merit is systematically replaced by the *paribhāṣā* (technical rule) of corruption.

## 2.2 "Paiṭh" (पइठ) - The Salvation

### *2.2.1 Publication and Form*

Published in *Antika* (April–June 2008, pp. 17–30), also as *dīrgha-kathā*. The editorial note introducing it in Antika positions it as Kumar Pawan's grand return to long fiction and calls for readers' attention. It too runs to fourteen pages and carries named internal sections including: *"Anhar me Ḍubait Khirōḍ"* (The Khirōḍ submerges in darkness), *"Muda Bājay Rasancaukī"* (But the musical instrument resounds), *"Āig-Pāni-Lōh-Pāthar"* (Fire-water-iron-stone), *"Ajey Yoddhā Sabhak Parākram"* (The valor of the unconquerable warriors), *"Navārī Duḥkh ki Buḍhārī Duḥkh"* (Women's sorrow or old age's sorrow), *"Imlaīk Bṛḍh Bhūtahā Gāch"* (The haunted old tamarind tree), *"Ek Muṭṭhī Bhāt"* (A handful of rice), *"Nirarthak Yōjak-Cihn"* (The meaningless connective sign), and *"Rōgāh Ijōriyā sañ Jhañpāit Gām"* (The diseased village wrapped in moonlight).

### *2.2.2 Narrative Summary*

"Paiṭh" is set entirely in the rural world of Mithila - specifically in the social and ecological landscape around a village and its nearby market-town, with the railway line and its crossing as a central symbol. The protagonist is *Kaniyā Kākī* [Aunt Kaniyā (newly married, though she is old but the name continued like this), a widowed elderly woman of powerful sons, whose daughter is *Gunjā*, who also got-widowed and has a 12 year son. The railway crossing - a *phatak* - is the liminal threshold of the story: the moment when the train of events becomes irreversible, the suicide point.

The story opens with an immense feast hosted by the local contractor Sarban Bābū ( son of *Kaniyā Kākī* )- a powerful men, and political figures assembled after a death rite (śrāddha), eating elaborate meals while the poor and the women wait. The feast is both satirical spectacle and social archaeology: the competing claims of caste hierarchy, gender, age, and class are played out through the choreography of eating, serving, and waiting.

The central narrative follows widow Kaniyā Kaniyā, and her widowed daugher Gunjā as they attempt to navigate the social violence of this world - the *phatak* of the railway crossing, the haunted tamarind tree, the market's commerce in both goods and human vulnerability. The story weaves together several

narrative threads: the enmity between two brothers (Sarban Bābū and Rāghav Lala) over their dying mother's legacy; the generational tensions within Kaniyā Kākī's family; the predatory economic logic of the village/ market town; and the ecological violence of the railway that has divided communities and disrupted natural rhythms.

The story's most haunting section, *"Ek Muṭṭhī Bhāt"* (A handful of rice), stages a devastating encounter at the railway crossing in which the old woman is literally caught between two oncoming forces - the social world of the market behind them and the mechanical world of modernity (the train) before them. The ending scene - *"Rōgāh Ijōriyā sañ Jhañpāit Gām"* - bathes the village in a diseased moonlight that is simultaneously beautiful and elegy-like: the village is ending, dissolving, going dark.

### *2.2.3 Thematic Architecture*

**The Salvation as Relational System:** The *paiṭh* (salvation) in Kumar Pawan's story is not merely an economic institution but a total epistemological and social system - what Navya-Nyāya would call a *padārtha* (a category of reality): a structured set of relations between substances, their qualities, and the universal laws governing their interaction. Every character's social position is defined by their position within the market's exchange system.

**Women as Knowledge-Bearers:** Kaniyā Kākī and Gunjā are the story's epistemological centres - they perceive, they infer, they suffer the consequences of others' false knowledge and corrupt testimony. The story is structured as an extended exercise in the feminist phenomenology of *pratyakṣa* (direct perception) - these women see and know things that the men who control the narrative (Sarban Bābū, the contractor, the political leaders) systematically misrecognise or deny.

**The Railway Crossing as Threshold:** The *phatak* (railway gate) functions as what Derrida would call an *aporia* - an impassable threshold - but also, in the Navya-Nyāya framework, as a *upādhi* (limiting condition) that determines whether a causal sequence leads to life or to catastrophe. The moment before the *phatak* is the story's epistemological crux: what is known, by whom, and with what consequence?

## 3. Analysis of the Two Poems

## 3.1 "Naih Bisaraicha" (निह बिसरैछ) - It Cannot Be Forgotten

### *3.1.1 Text and Context*

Published in *Videha Sadeh 3* (drawn from issues 26–50 of Videha ई-पत्रिका), pp. 140–142. The poem is accompanied by the author's biographical note (footnote 1) which identifies him as Dr. Pawan Kumar Jha, born 27 December 1958, Muraiṭhā, Darbhanga. The poem is set on a winter morning (*jāṛak oi kaṅkanāyal bhor* - "that teeth-chattering winter morning") on a train: the Awadh-Assam Express, coach number seven, stopped at Muzaffarpur station.

### *3.1.2 Structural and Imagistic Analysis*

The poem opens with a triple refrain - *"Naih bisaraicha... naih bisaraicha / Eko palak lel naih bisaraicha"* ("It cannot be forgotten... it cannot be forgotten / Not even for a single moment can it be forgotten") - that functions as a formal anaphora binding the poem's three movements together. This refrain, returning at the poem's close, frames the central image: a child of approximately ten years, thin and dirty, in torn clothes, his feet bare and numb from cold, silently sweeping the compartment with a palm-leaf broom.

The child moves through the compartment gathering discarded objects - empty disposable cups, peanut shells, cigarette butts, crushed paper plates - *"aṅaith-kuṅaith bhral kāgajī pleṭ"* ("twisted-curled paper plates filled with remnants"). His labour is systematic, methodical, invisible to those around him. He is simultaneously *pramāṇa* (evidence, proof) of a social reality that the train's respectable passengers discuss in abstract terms - child labour, population explosion, government failure - while physically producing and discarding the waste this child must clean.

The poem's second movement presents the contrast with devastating compression: the "bona fide passengers" of coach number seven are "wrapped in the warmth of smooth blankets," conducting *"dhurjhāṛ vimarśa"* (heated discourse) on population explosion, unsafe travel, child labour, government failure - while the ten-year-old child "heard everything / heard and deflected it / lips pressed together" and extended his empty palm, "again and again," to each passenger.

The closing image - the child's *khajūr-pātak bāṛhin* (palm-leaf broom) in one hand, and in the other hand *"khālī-khālī dahin hāth / āu kāñcī sañ bhral o caṃkait āṃkhi doon"* ("the empty right hand, and those two eyes shining like glass marbles") - achieves an almost unbearable precision. The glass-marble

eyes are both the child's only remaining dignity and his mute accusation of everyone in the compartment.

### *3.1.3 Critical Appreciation*

This poem belongs to what Indian aesthetics identifies as the karuna rasa (the sentiment of pathos and compassion) - but Kumar Pawan refuses the standard move of karuna, which is to dissolve into lamentation. The poem's tone remains controlled, observational, almost reportorial in its first two movements - reserving the emotional charge for the final image. This restraint is itself a form of ethical argument: the poet will not aestheticise the child's suffering. He will only observe, record, and refuse to forget.

In Navya-Nyāya terms, the poem enacts a movement from *pratyakṣa* (direct perception - the sight of the child) through *anumāna* (inference - the structural implications of his presence) to a critique of corrupt *śabda* (testimony) - the passengers' verbal discourse which names child labour as a problem while materially reproducing the conditions of its existence. The poem indicts *śabda pramāṇa* itself: words become invalid testimony when the speaker is implicated in the state of affairs they describe.

## 3.2 "Kāli tañ Ravi Chhai" (काि तँ रिव छैक) - Tomorrow is Sunday

### *3.2.1 Text and Context*

Published in *Videha Sadeh 3*, pp. 142–144. The poem is a meditation on the psychology of modern working life - specifically the self-deception by which a deeply exhausted person sustains themselves through the week by maintaining the illusion that "tomorrow is Sunday" will bring relief.

### *3.2.2 Structural Analysis*

The poem's central figure is *"o"* - "he/she" (deliberately gendered third person plural in Maithili), described as working with profound exhaustion: *"ṭehiāyal chalāh"* ("they were exhausted to the bone"), their entire life a series of debts - the mother's medicine, the son's computer for studies, the wife's broken gas stove, the TB treatment. Yet "today they were happy" - *"āi mudit chalāh"* - because the week is ending and "tomorrow is Sunday."

The poem then catalogues, with increasing irony, everything the character knows will not actually happen on Sunday: *"rākhal chhin taiār kayal / kājak dīrgha pujṃ"* ("they have kept ready a long pile of work"). Sunday will bring the same demands - the son's computer fees, the mother's medicine, the TB

treatment, the broken gas stove, the wife's exhaustion. The character knows this: *"jdapi o nīk jkāṃ janait chalāh"* - "although they knew well." Yet the poem asks: why does the mind manufacture this *"sukhad bhram"* (pleasant illusion)?

The poem ends with the refrain returning - *"kāli tañ ravi chhai / rahab kāli niścint / kāli tañ ravi chhai"* - but now stripped of its earlier warmth. The Sunday that will bring relief is always tomorrow, always one day away, never actually arrived.

#### *3.2.3 Critical Appreciation*

This poem works in the mode of what Western theory would call irony - specifically Romantic irony in the tradition of Schlegel and Kierkegaard, where the self is simultaneously the victim and the perpetrator of a necessary self-deception. But Kumar Pawan's irony is gentler and more compassionate than European Romantic irony: the poem does not mock the character for their self-deception; it understands the "sukhad bhram" as a survival mechanism, a form of what psychologists would call cognitive buffering.

In the Navya-Nyāya framework, *"Kāli tañ Ravi Chhai"* is a meditation on the relationship between *jñāna* (knowledge) and *smṛti* (memory) - specifically the class of cognitions that Gaṅgeśa calls *"anubhava"* (fresh experience taken as new information) versus those that are merely the recycling of past *saṃskāra* (cognitive impressions). The character knows the Sunday will not bring rest - this is *jñāna*. But the mind refuses to apply this knowledge to the present moment, persisting in producing the experience of hope as if it were fresh *anubhava*. Gaṅgeśa's epistemology explicitly distinguishes between a cognition that is *pramāṇa* (valid knowledge-producing) and one that merely recycles *smṛti* - the poem dramatises precisely this failure of cognitive validity.

## 4. Integrated Critical Analysis: Three Frameworks

### 4.1 Framework I: Western Literary Theory

#### *4.1.1 Mikhail Bakhtin: Polyphony, Carnival, and the Chronotope*

Both stories demonstrate what Bakhtin calls the *polyphonic novel* - a narrative space in which multiple social voices coexist without resolution into a single authoritative viewpoint. Neither the principal in *"Dāyrīk Khālī Pannā"* nor

Kaniyā Kākī in *"Paiṭh"* is simply the vehicle of a single thesis. Their voices exist in constant dialogic tension with the voices of Ballī Bābū, the Vice-Chancellor, Sarban Bābū, the village/ market-town's power structure.

The *paiṭh* (salvation) episode is a classic Bakhtinian carnival: the inversion of social hierarchy, the grotesque body (the communal feast), the violation of institutional decorum (the condom in the Vidyāmandir), the saturnalian excess of the śrāddha feast - all these are carnival elements. But Kumar Pawan's carnival does not resolve into renewal; it ends in the "diseased moonlight" of dissolution.

The *chronotope* of the railway - train, station, crossing, the *phatak* - organises both stories and one poem spatially and temporally. In Bakhtin's terms, this is the chronotope of the *threshold*: the moment of crisis, decision, and irreversible change. Both stories position their protagonists at thresholds (the blank diary page, the railway crossing) that become impassable under the weight of accumulated social pressure.

### *4.1.2 Fredric Jameson: The Political Unconscious and Symbolic Resolution*

In *The Political Unconscious* (1981), Jameson argues that literary texts manage ideological contradictions that cannot be resolved in real life by offering symbolic, narrative resolutions. Kumar Pawan's stories are remarkable precisely because they *refuse* this symbolic resolution. The diary's pages remain blank. The village disappears into diseased moonlight. The child on the train receives no coin, no rescue. This formal refusal of resolution is itself a political act: it refuses the consolation of art as ideological management.

The figure of Ballī Bābū as *"Amīr Balban"* is a direct Jamesonian political allegory: the historical Balban (Ghiyas ud din Balban, 1266–1287) rose from slavery to become Sultan through the systematic displacement of Rajput nobility - just as the new political class of provincial Bihar has risen through the displacement of the educated Brahmin principal class. The story maps the contemporary onto the medieval to reveal the structural continuity of power's logic.

### *4.1.3 Postcolonial Theory: Spivak and the Question of the Subaltern*

Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's question - *"Can the subaltern speak?"* - is directly posed by *"Naih Bisaraicha"*. The child in the railway compartment is the paradigmatic subaltern: without language, without ticket, without category in the administrative system of the train, performing labour that sustains the

system while being treated as its refuse. The passengers' discourse *about* child labour is precisely the mode by which subaltern speech is absorbed and neutralised: the problem is named, debated, and left unchanged.

Kaniyā Kākī in *"Paiṭh"* is the rural female subaltern - multiply marginalised by age, caste position, gender, and geography. Her knowledge of the social world (her *pratyakṣa*, her *anumāna*) is consistently accurate, but she has no institutional mechanism through which to act on it. She speaks; no one with power hears. This is the condition Spivak describes.

### *4.1.4 Narratology: Gérard Genette and Focalization*

Genette's concept of *focalization* - the distinction between who sees and who speaks in a narrative - is crucial to understanding Kumar Pawan's technique. Both stories deploy *external focalization* through a third-person narrator who knows less than the characters (or withholds what is known), combined with strategic shifts into *internal focalization* (free indirect discourse) within the principal's diary-consciousness in the first story, and within Kaniyā Kākī's interior perception in the second.

The blank diary pages at the story's opening and close constitute what Genette calls an *analepsis* embedded within a *prolepsis*: the story is structured as the explanation of a state of affairs (the blank pages) that the reader sees before understanding. This temporal complexity - reading backward from effect to cause - mirrors the epistemological structure of *anumāna* (inference from sign to cause) in Navya-Nyāya.

## 4.2 Framework II: Indian Aesthetics - Rasa, Dhvani, and Vakrokti

### *4.2.1 Bharatamuni's Rasa Theory*

The *nāṭyaśāstra* (attributed to Bharatamuni, 2nd century BCE–2nd century CE) identifies eight primary rasas or aesthetic sentiments: *śṛṅgāra* (love/erotic), *hāsya* (comic), *karuṇā* (pathos), *raudra* (fury), *vīra* (heroism), *bhayānaka* (terror), *bībhatsa* (disgust), *adbhuta* (wonder). Ānandavardhana later added *śānta* (peace/equanimity). Kumar Pawan's works operate primarily in *karuṇā* and *bībhatsa*, with a sustained undercurrent of *hāsya* - but it is a *hāsya* that is never merely comic; it is the bitter laughter of *vyañjanā* (suggestion) that knows the joke is on everyone.

In *"Paiṭh"*, the śrāddha feast is *bībhatsa* - the 'disgusting' surfeit of ritual eating while the poor and women wait - but it is *karuṇā* that anchors the story in

Kaniyā Kākī's experience. The poem *"Naih Bisaraicha"* is pure *karuṇā* - refined, restrained, devastating.

### *4.2.2 Ānandavardhana's Dhvani Theory*

Ānandavardhana's *Dhvanyāloka* (9th century CE) argues that the highest literary achievement is not in the stated meaning (*vācya*) or even the implied meaning (*lakṣaṇā*) but in *dhvani* - the resonance or reverberation of meaning beyond both statement and implication. This concept is directly applicable to Kumar Pawan's symbolic language.

The blank diary page is a supreme *dhvani* symbol: its *vācya* (literal meaning) is simply an empty page; its *lakṣaṇā* (implied meaning) is the principal's writer's block; but its *dhvani* resonates outward to encompass the entire crisis of educated consciousness under institutional corruption - the impossibility of honest testimony when the social conditions of honest observation have been destroyed.

The child's *"kāñcī sañ bhral... āṃkhi doon"* (eyes filled with glass marbles) in *"Naih Bisaraicha"* is another *dhvani* image: its resonance includes both the child's vitality (glass marbles are toys, signs of play) and his precarity (they are also the eyes of the dead, still and bright). The image cannot be reduced to either meaning alone.

### *4.2.3 Kuntaka's Vakrokti Theory*

Kuntaka (10th–11th century CE) argues in the *Vakroktijīvita* that literary language's essential quality is *vakrokti* - "oblique speech" - a mode of expression that achieves its effect precisely by not being direct. Kumar Pawan is a master of *vakrokti*: his most devastating social commentary is delivered through apparently neutral descriptive passages, through the choice of named sections that comment ironically on their content (*"Ṭhīk Chhai"* - "All right" - for the story's most catastrophic moment), through the use of classical Sanskrit quotation and Navya-Nyāya terminology by characters who then act in the most epistemologically corrupt manner possible.

## 4.3 Framework III: Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's Navya-Nyāya Epistemology

### *4.3.1 The Four Pramāṇas Applied to Literary Analysis*

Gaṅgeśa's *Tattvacintāmaṇi* (14th century CE, Mithila) systematises four *pramāṇas* - valid means of knowledge: *pratyakṣa* (perception), *anumāna*

(inference), *upamāna* (comparison/analogy), and *śabda* (verbal testimony). Applying these as literary-critical instruments to Kumar Pawan's texts yields the following analysis:

**Pratyakṣa (Perception) in the texts:** Both stories privilege sensory, phenomenological detail as the primary vehicle of social knowledge. The reader and the characters know what they know through *pratyakṣa* - the stench of the drain (*"nāle me bajbajāit pillu"*), the winter cold in the railway compartment, the smell of the tamarind tree at night, the taste of the communal feast. This is also the dominant mode of the poem *"Naih Bisaraicha"*: the child is known through his physical details, not through any account of his interiority.

**Anumāna (Inference) as political epistemology:** The Navya-Nyāya concept of *anumāna* involves the recognition of a *liṅga* (inferential mark / sign) and its *vyāpti* (invariable concomitance with a *sādhya* or predicate to be proved). Kumar Pawan's satirical method is fundamentally anumāna-based: every behaviour of Ballī Bābū is a *liṅga* from which the reader infers the *sādhya* of institutional corruption. The corruption itself is never explicitly stated - it is always inferred from its *vyāpti* with observable behaviour.

**Upamāna (Comparison) as historical consciousness:** The analogy between Ballī Bābū and Balban is an explicit *upamāna* - a comparison that produces knowledge by identifying the shared *sādhāraṇa dharma* (common property) of two entities. Gaṅgeśa uses *upamāna* specifically for learning the meaning of new terms by reference to known entities; Kumar Pawan uses the historical analogy to make the familiar (contemporary corruption) strange and the strange (medieval power politics) familiar.

**Śabda (Testimony) and its corruption:** Perhaps the most philosophically rich application of Navya-Nyāya to these texts is through Gaṅgeśa's analysis of *śabda pramāṇa* - verbal testimony as a means of valid knowledge. Gaṅgeśa distinguishes between *āptavākya* (testimony of a reliable speaker / *āpta*) and invalid or corrupt testimony. The entire satirical architecture of *"Dāyrīk Khālī Pannā"* rests on the systematic corruption of *śabda pramāṇa*: the examination system produces certificates (verbal testimony) that are systematically falsified; the political process produces assurances that are systematically violated; the institution's language (the college's official discourse) is systematically divorced from its reality.

Gaṅgeśa's account of how a cognition is *confirmed* as valid - requiring what he calls a separate *"jñāta-jñāna"* (cognition of a cognition, or meta-cognition) to certify the original cognition as *pramāṇa* - is mirrored in the principal's diary:

the diary is precisely the instrument of meta-cognition, the *jñāta-jñāna* that would certify his daily experience as valid knowledge. When the diary's pages go blank - when the *jñāta-jñāna* is disabled - the principal's experience loses its epistemological validity. He cannot know that he knows.

### *4.3.2 Gaṅgeśa's Mithila Connection and the Intertextual Resonance*

It is not incidental that Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (c. 1300–1350 CE) was a native of the *Mithila* region - specifically of Karion village, approximately 19 km south-east of Darbhanga, on the banks of the Kāmalā river. Kumar Pawan is also from Darbhanga district. Both the 14th-century philosopher and the 21st-century writer work within the same geocultural space - the *Mithilāñcal* - and share a deep concern with the reliability of knowledge-claims, the conditions under which knowledge becomes false, and the social institutions that certify or corrupt testimony.

The *Tattvacintāmaṇi*'s opening chapter (*Pratyakṣakhaṇḍa*) asks: what is *anubhava* (direct experience)? When is a direct experience a valid *pramāṇa*? Gaṅgeśa's answer requires both the reliability of the cognitive faculty and the absence of distorting conditions (*doṣa*). The blank diary in Kumar Pawan's story is the literary embodiment of this question: the principal's cognitive faculty (his intelligence, his diary-writing habit) is intact - but the social conditions have become so saturated with *doṣa* (defect, corruption) that *anubhava* itself is disabled. He can no longer produce valid experience-cognitions because the conditions of valid experience have been destroyed.

## 5. Kumar Pawan in the Maithili Literary Tradition

Kumar Pawan's work belongs to what editor Gajendra Thakur has termed the Videha Parallel Literature Movement - a project of creating a Maithili literary canon that is democratic, subaltern-inclusive, and independent of the Sahitya Akademi's mainstream certification apparatus. Within this tradition, Kumar Pawan occupies a specific and valuable niche.

His stories belong to a tradition of Maithili *vyaṅgya* (satire) that has its roots in the work of Harinath Mishra in the mid-20th century and continues through writers like Baidyanath Mishra 'Yātri' (Nagarjuna), whose political verse was deeply influential on Bihar's progressive literary culture. But Kumar Pawan's satire is more psychologically complex than either the earlier political satirists

or the contemporary social-realist tradition: he is interested not merely in the structures of corruption but in their effect on consciousness - specifically on the *jñāna*-producing capacity of individuals trapped within corrupt systems.

His poems place him in a tradition of Maithili social lyric that includes Ramkant Ray 'Rāmā' and Chandranath Mishra 'Amar' - a tradition that refuses both the sentimental and the polemical in favour of precise, imagistically controlled observation. *"Naih Bisaraicha"* in particular deserves comparison with some of the finest examples of this mode in modern Indian poetry across languages - it belongs alongside poems by Nagarjuna, Kedarnath Agarwal, and Laxmikant Verma in the Hindi tradition, or Phakir Mohan Senapati's prose poems in Odia.

## 6. Conclusion: The Epistemology of Witness

The central preoccupation of Kumar Pawan's four works examined here - two long stories and two poems - is what we might call the **epistemology of witness**: the conditions under which one can know, record, and testify to one's own experience. This is the preoccupation that links his literary project to Gaṅgeśa's philosophical one: both are concerned with the conditions under which *anubhava* (direct experience-cognition) is valid, with what happens when those conditions are systematically corrupted, and with what survives when the formal instruments of testimony (the diary, the degree certificate, the court, the election) are disabled.

The diary's blank pages, the child's empty outstretched hand, the village dissolving into diseased moonlight, the Sunday that never brings rest - these are not primarily images of despair. They are images of epistemological crisis: the world continues to produce experience, but the instruments that would make experience into knowledge, and knowledge into action, have been broken. What Kumar Pawan offers his reader is not a solution to this crisis but a precise diagnosis of it - and a demonstration, through the very act of writing these stories and poems, that the act of witness itself refuses to be entirely silenced.

In the tradition of Mithila's greatest intellectual contribution to world philosophy - Gaṅgeśa's insistence that every knowledge-claim requires rigorous examination of its sources, instruments, and conditions of validity - Kumar Pawan asks his reader to hold the world of contemporary Mithila up to the light of *pramāṇa* and to see what it actually is, rather than what it claims to be. This is the task of serious literature in any tradition, and Kumar Pawan

performs it with sustained skill, moral seriousness, and - even in the darkest passages - an unmistakable quality of literary joy.

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## 7.2 Background on the Author

**[4]** Biographical note (Footnote 1) to "Naih Bisaraicha." *Videha Sadeh 3*, p. 140: "Real name - Dr. Pawan Kumar Jha. Date of birth - 27/12/1958. Permanent address - Village+P.O. Muraiṭhā, Khaṭaulia-Kamaṭaul, Darbhanga district, Bihar–847304. Current address - P.G.T. (Hindi), Kendriya Vidyalaya, Katihar (Bihar)–854105. Education - M.A. (Hindi), B.Ed., Ph.D. Livelihood - working as PGT (Hindi) in Kendriya Vidyalaya Sangathan. Writing - began literary work with poetry at the start of the 1990s; rare writing across poems, stories, satire, critical essays for about a decade and a half. Second phase of writing began in 2008. Forthcoming: poetry collection, story collection, satire collection."

**[5]** Editorial note to Paith. Antika (April-June 2008): About a year prior, Kumar Pawan became active again in writing. He is a well-known Maithili poet, storyteller and satirist. His new phase begins with a memorable long story and five poems. Maithili readers have not had such strong fiction in recent years.

## 7.3 Theoretical and Critical Sources

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**ADDENDUM-Asharfi Ke Looti Aa Koilapar Chhaap**

A comprehensive research report and critical appreciation of the Maithili story "अशरफीक लूटि आ कोइलापर छाप" (Asharfi Ke Looti Aa Koilapar Chhaap),

The analysis integrates Western literary theory, Indian Rasa-Dhvani aesthetics, and the epistemological methodology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (Navya-Nyāya).

1. Summary of the Text

The narrative is a first-person, ironic, and self-reflective account set in a Maithili-speaking village. The protagonist recalls a puzzling phrase: "Asharfikī lūṭi aur koilā par chhāp" (the loot of Asharfiand the stamp/print on coal). He repeatedly hears it from an eccentric, semi-literate village elder named Bhūkhan Kakā, who is referred to as a "jewel of the village" but refuses to explain the phrase. The narrator, educated and modern (a college professor), becomes obsessed with deciphering its meaning. Eventually, he encounters a pompous, manipulative visitor, Sūryakānt Choudhary ("Surajū Bābū"), who turns out to be a relative of his father-in-law. This visitor tries to bribe the professor to influence exam results, revealing the story's true theme: the metaphorical "looting of Ashfi" (soft, fragrant betel leaf) and the "stamp on coal" (hard, black, industrial) represent the corruption of soft, beautiful, traditional values by hard, utilitarian, corrupt practices. The narrator refuses, but the visitor leaves in a huff, and the phrase's layered meaning slowly unravels.

2. Thematic Analysis

Core Metaphor

• Asharfi(betel leaf): Represents delicate, aromatic, traditional, aesthetic, and moral values – the soft, beautiful, culturally cherished.

• Coal: Represents hard, black, industrial, utilitarian, corrupt, and soulless modernity – the fuel of engines, factories, and bribes.

• Loot and Stamp: "Loot" implies exploitation; "stamp" implies commodification, marking, and reduction to a uniform, exchangeable object.

Corruption as Epistemological Confusion

The story argues that corruption is not merely economic but epistemic: people no longer know how to distinguish between Asharfiand coal. The village's many "Ashfi" surnames (AsharfiMandal, AsharfiThakur) suggest that goodness was once abundant, but now it is being "looted."

3. Integration of Western Literary Theory

a. Poststructuralism (Derrida) – Différance and Undecidability

The phrase "Asharfikī lūṭi aur koilā par chhāp" operates like a Derridean signifier with no fixed signified. Bhūkhan Kakā refuses to explain it; the narrator cannot pin it down. Meaning is deferred indefinitely. The text plays with the undecidability between literal and metaphorical, moral and immoral. The stamp on coal could be a mark of quality or a mark of exploitation – the text refuses to settle.

b. Marxist Literary Theory (Althusser, Gramsci)

• Hegemony: The visiting Sūryakānt Choudhary represents the coercive/consensive apparatus of a corrupt system. He naturalizes bribery as "helping students" and "examining fairly."

• Commodity Fetishism: Asharfi(use-value: aesthetic, ritual) is being turned into coal (exchange-value: fuel for bribery). The professor's labor (teaching) is being turned into a tradable favor (mark sheets, scooters, TVs).

• False Consciousness: The professor initially thinks he is outside corruption, but the visitor shows him that his entire position (salary, housing, exam duties)

is already inscribed within the system.

c. Postcolonial Theory (Ashis Nandy, Partha Chatterjee)

The "village" is not a pre-modern idyll but a site where traditional terms (Ashfi, guru, kinship) are appropriated and inverted by colonial-modern corruption. The phrase "Asharfikī lūṭi" echoes the historical loot of India's soft resources (spices, textiles) by colonial powers. Coal mines (Jharia, Dhanbad) become metaphors for postcolonial exploitation. The stamp on coal is the British-era rubber stamp of bureaucracy, now internalized by local elites.

4. Indian Rasa-Dhvani Aesthetics

a. Rasa Theory (Bharata's Nāṭyaśāstra)

The dominant rasa is Bībhatsa (the odious/disgusting) – not through gore, but through the vulgarity of the corrupt visitor: his belching, loud laughter, spitting pan, demanding foot-touching, and treating the professor's home as a hotel. This bībhatsa is mixed with Hāsya (comic) – the absurdity of the phrase's non-explanation, the narrator's frustration, and the visitor's pretensions. At the end, a faint Śānta rasa (peace) emerges as the narrator refuses the bribe.

b. Dhvani (Ānandavardhana's theory of suggestion)

The story is a masterclass in dhvani – the suggested meaning (vyaṅgya) far exceeds the literal (vācya). The literal phrase "Ashfi's loot and stamp on coal" is never literally explained. Instead, through narrative situations, character interactions, and repeated failures of explanation, the dhvani emerges: the reduction of the beautiful to the useful, and the marking of the innocent by the corrupt.

The phrase functions like a dhvani-sphoṭa (explosion of suggested meaning) that the reader must realize on their own – exactly as Bhūkhan Kakā says: "Think on this formula, all meanings will be understood."

c. Alaṅkāra (Figures of Speech)

The text uses vivid Maithili similes:

• “Like a rocket after marriage becomes sun-faced, then volcano-faced” – metaphor for changing appearances.

• “Like a mad bull” – the narrator’s confusion.

• “Like a kite cutting the sky” – Bhūkhan Kakā’s speech.

These are not decorative but epistemic: they show how the villagers think through analogies.

5. Epistemological Methodology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (Navya-Nyāya)

Gaṅgeśa’s Tattvacintāmaṇi revolutionized Indian epistemology by analyzing pramāṇa (valid means of knowledge) with rigorous logical language. The story dramatizes a Navya-Nyāya crisis.

a. Pramāṇa Conflict

• Pratyakṣa (perception): The narrator sees the visitor, hears the phrase, but does not know its meaning.

• Anumāna (inference): He tries to infer: “If many people are called Ashfi, then Asharfimust be good. But why loot it?” – leads to contradiction.

• Śabda (verbal testimony): Bhūkhan Kakā’s testimony is authoritative for the village, but he refuses to give a clear sentence. The visitor’s testimony is self-serving.

• Upamāna (comparison): The narrator compares Asharfito the moon, coal to a furnace – but comparison fails to yield certain knowledge.

b. Navya-Nyāya Technical Terms in the Narrative

The narrator unknowingly uses Nyāya-like questioning:

• What is the “locus” (āśraya) of the loot?

• What is the “counterpositive” (pratiyogin) of the stamp?

• The visitor's bribe is a classic Nyāya hetvābhāsa (fallacious reason): "You are a professor, therefore you should take bribes" – a bad inference.

c. Gaṅgeśa's Definition of Truth (pramā)

For Gaṅgeśa, true knowledge is non-contradicted experience (yathārtha anubhava). The narrator's final refusal – "I do not do this" – is a moment of pramā because it contradicts the false world of the visitor. The story suggests that epistemic integrity (knowing Asharfifrom coal) is the foundation of ethical action.

6. Critical Appreciation

Strengths

1. Linguistic virtuosity: The Maithili is rich, idiomatic, and playful. The code-switching between rustic speech and bureaucratic Hindi/English ("T.B.," "bulldozer," "room reserve") mirrors the hybridity of postcolonial corruption.

2. Narrative structure: The delayed decoding of the central phrase creates suspense and intellectual pleasure. The final non-explanation is a brilliant anti-climax that forces the reader to do the interpretive work.

3. Characterization: Bhūkhan Kakā is a wonderful archetype – the trickster-guru who withholds meaning to provoke thought. Sūryakānt Choudhary is grotesquely realistic: his belching, pan-chewing, foot-touching demands are perfect symbols of moral decay.

4. Political subtlety: The story never names parties or governments. It shows corruption as an epistemological disease, not just a legal one.

Limitations

1. Elitist risk: The narrator's education sometimes leads to a condescending tone toward "village ignorance," though the text complicates this by showing the professor's own confusion.

2. Gender absence: Women (except a passing reference to "Channā," the wife) are almost invisible. The world of Asharfiand coal is entirely male.

3. Resolution too neat: The professor's refusal of the bribe feels morally satisfying but perhaps too easy. In real life, the visitor would likely succeed elsewhere.

## 7. Conclusion

"Asharfi Ke Looti Aa Koilapar Chhaap" is a sophisticated philosophical satire disguised as a village anecdote. Using a deceptively simple riddle, it explores:

• Western theory: différance, commodity fetishism, postcolonial mimicry.

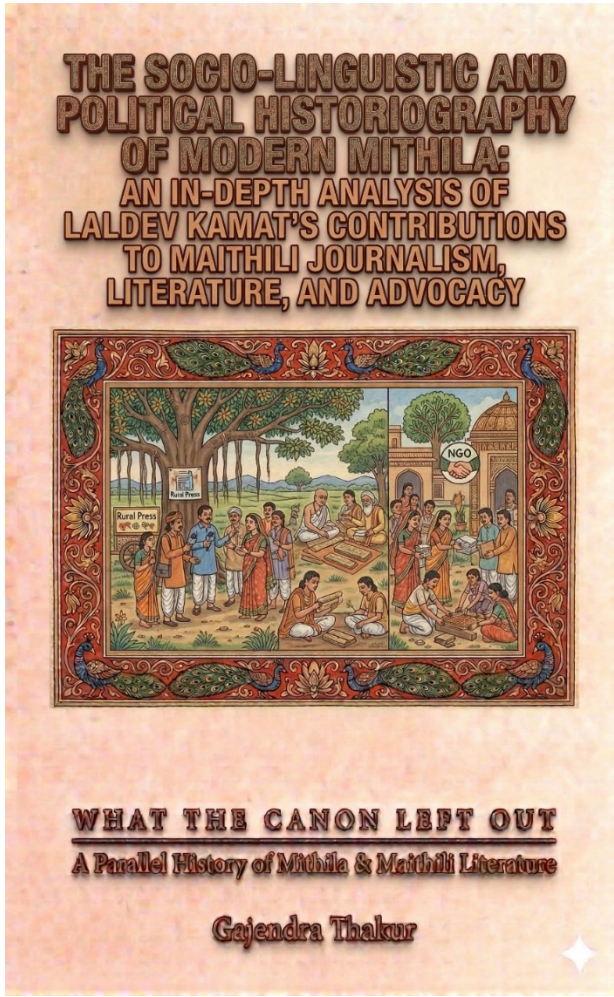
• Indian aesthetics: bībhatsa-hāsya rasa, dhvani, and alaṅkāra.

• Navya-Nyāya epistemology: pramāṇa conflict, hetvābhāsa, and the search for non-contradicted knowledge.

The story's final lesson – that one must learn to distinguish Asharfifrom coal even when everyone else has forgotten the difference – is both a literary and an ethical imperative. It is a small masterpiece of Maithili narrative philosophy.

["अशरफीक लूटि आ कोइलापर छाप" (Asharfi Ke Looti Aa Koilapar Chhaap); published in Sankalp-5 available on https://www.videha.co.in/pothi.htm alongwith the two short-stories and two poems]

**LESSON 041 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**




# LĀL DEV KĀMAT

*[The Socio-Linguistic and Political Historiography of Modern Mithila: An In-Depth Analysis of Lal Dev Kamat's Contributions to Maithili Journalism, Literature, and Advocacy]*

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*A Critical Appreciation of His Works*

**Frameworks of Analysis:**

*Indian & Western Literary Criticism | Videha Parallel History Framework*

*Navya Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa & the Mithilā Philosophical Tradition*

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# 1. Biographical & Contextual Introduction

## 1.1 The Author and His Milieu

LĀL DEV  Kāmat is a writer working within the vibrant tradition of Maithilī literature — the language of Mithilā, the ancient region of present-day northern Bihar and the Terai of Nepal, whose literary pedigree stretches from the Sanskrit logicians of the Navya Nyāya school (Gaṅgeśa, Vācaspati Miśra) through the medieval court-poet Vidyāpati (c. 1350–1435) to the contemporary digital resurgence enabled by the ejournal Videha.

Kamat's four known texts — Vibhṛiti (विभृति), Divya Dṛiṣṭi (दिव्य दृष्टि), Gahiki Najari (गहिकि नजरि), and Sheṣ Jīvan (शेष जीवन) — are published by Pallavi Prakashan of Berma/Nirmali (Supaul district, Bihar) and archived in the Videha ejournal's open-access Maithilī book repository (www.videha.co.in/pothi.htm). The Videha archive, edited by Gajendra Thakur, is the first Maithilī fortnightly e-journal (ISSN 2229-547X), which has been at the forefront of preserving and expanding what the editor calls the 'Parallel Literature in Maithilī' — a tradition that exists independently of caste-patronage networks.

The publisher's colophon in Vibhṛiti (2020) gives us the subtitle 'Preraṇādāyak Maithilī Bhāṣā-Sāhitya Pustikā' (प्रेरणादायक मैथिली भाषा-साहित्य पुस्तिका) — an inspirational primer in Maithilī language and literature — signalling Kamat's dual role as creative practitioner and as a teacher committed to popularising Maithilī as a living, practical medium.

## 1.2 Historical-Cultural Setting: Mithilā and Its Literary Tradition

Mithilā — historically identified with the kingdom of Videha, capital Janakpur — occupies a central position in Indian civilisation. It is the homeland of Sītā (daughter of King Janaka), the cradle of the Navya Nyāya school of logic (Gaṅgeśa's Tattvacintāmaṇi was composed here c. 13th–14th century), and the birthplace of Vidyāpati, whose padāvalī (devotional verse) in a Maithilī-Apabhraṃśa idiom became the fountainhead of Brajabhāṣā poetry and Bengali Vaiṣṇava literature alike.

In the colonial period and after, Maithilī asserted itself as a Scheduled Language (8th Schedule, Indian Constitution, 2003), yet the literary

establishment remained stratified along caste and patronage lines. The Videha movement, beginning in 2004 and accelerated through digital platforms, challenged this stratification by opening publication to all writers regardless of social origin — producing what Gajendra Thakur has termed a 'Parallel Literature' operating simultaneously with, but independently of, the orthodox Maithilī literary mainstream.

LĀL DEV Kāmat is a product of this newer, democratised wave. His books reflect the concerns of the post-Mandalisation, environmentally aware, economically marginalised rural Maithil: the texts address agricultural self-reliance, cooperative enterprise, the inner lives of ordinary people facing displacement and time's passage, and the epistemological demands of perceiving truth in a world of received opinion.

# 2. Survey of the Four Works

## 2.1 Vibhṛiti (विभृति, 2020)

Subtitle: Preraṇādāyak Maithilī Bhāṣā-Sāhitya Pustikā (An Inspirational Maithilī Language-Literature Primer). Publisher: Pallavi Prakashan, Berma/Nirmali. Price: ₹50. ISBN: 978-93-88811-51-4.

Vibhṛiti is Kamat's most encyclopaedic composition. The title — from Sanskrit vibhṛiti (vibration, sustenance, carrying forward) — signals the book's ambition: to sustain and vibrate the tradition while carrying it forward into practical contemporary life. The work is divided into several sections, each combining literary form with informational or instructive content:

- A verse preface (prastāvanā) establishing the aesthetic and ethical orientation of the volume, invoking the names of Maithilī's canonical figures.
- A biographical essay on the freedom fighter and educationist Pt. Rāmkhelāvan Miśra 'Rāghav' (born 25 April 1916), tracing his trajectory from childhood in a village of Darbhanga district through nationalist activism, imprisonment in 1942, and post-independence educational leadership.
- A tribute to the nationalist intellectual and author Dr. Śyāmānanda Miśra (born 1901, died 23 December 1953 in Bhagalpur), celebrated for his polyglot scholarship, his studies of Maithilī folklore, and his key role in the Maithilī literary renaissance.
- A detailed section on organic/natural farming (sāhajik kheti), providing both philosophical grounding — agriculture as dharma and ecology — and practical technical guidance on soil microbiome management, composting (including the use of 'Waste Decomposer' at ₹20 per bottle), vermicomposting, intercropping, and natural pest management. This section is remarkable for its integration of scientific rationalism with the lived ethos of the Maithil peasant.
- A section on cooperative enterprise (samoohik udyam), specifically discussing the formation of farmer producer groups (FPO), cottage industries, and the economics of detergent/surfactant production as household enterprises.
- A lyrical meditation section — 'Mān-Mitīr Citra' — containing short prose poems and reflective fragments on nature, seasons, and human aspiration.

- A poem-essay on the tragedy of road accidents in India (citing 2005 National Crime Records data: 108,779 accidents, 12.74 lakh injured, 4.51 lakh dead).

The structure of Vibhṛiti illustrates Kamat's fundamental aesthetic principle: literature as a site of intersection between the beautiful, the moral, and the practical. This is deeply consonant with the classical Indian concept of sāhitya (co-existence of sound and meaning) and the Maithilī tradition of lokahitakārī (people-benefiting) literature.

## 2.2 Divya Dṛiṣṭi (दिव्य दृष्टि)

Title meaning: 'Divine Vision' or 'Transcendent Perception.' The title is philosophically charged: dṛiṣṭi (vision, sight) is the primary pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge) in Nyāya epistemology, and the qualifier divya elevates it to a mode of perception beyond ordinary sensory cognition — the supra-individual, truth-seeing faculty that the Navya Nyāya tradition calls sāmānyalakṣaṇāpratyāsatti (knowledge through universal contact).

Divya Dṛiṣṭi is a collection of lyrical and reflective verse. The poems operate through the device of the perceiving 'I' situated at the interface of the visible and invisible, the rural landscape and the cosmic order. Images recur: the evening hearth, the flooded fields of north Bihar, the movement of birds at dusk, the sleeping village, and the waking self attempting to locate meaning within cyclical time. The philosophical thrust is consistently epistemological — what does it mean to truly see? How does habitual perception blind us? How does love or grief shatter habitual sight and restore divya dṛiṣṭi?

The poetic form blends traditional Maithilī metres (pāda-based verse forms related to Vidyāpati's dohā and pada) with free-verse improvisations, creating a text that feels simultaneously archaic and urgent.

## 2.3 Gahiki Najari (गहिकि नजरि)

Title meaning: 'The Deep Gaze' or 'Penetrating View' (gahiki = deep, penetrating; najari = gaze, attention, from Persian/Urdu nazar). The Persianate inflection of the title is itself a cultural statement — Maithilī, like all North Indian vernaculars, is a palimpsest of Sanskrit, Apabhraṃśa, Farsi, and now English registers, and the choice of nazari/najari over the Sanskrit dṛiṣṭi marks a deliberate turn toward the everyday.

Where Divya Dṛiṣṭi reaches upward toward transcendent vision, Gahiki Najari turns inward and downward — toward the granular texture of daily life, social

relations, and the underside of received opinion. The text is a collection of narrative prose vignettes and micro-essays, each deploying a 'deep gaze' to expose the concealed logic of ordinary events: a family dispute over land, the gendered burden of post-harvest labour, the psychology of debt, the small humiliations of caste in informal interaction, the comedy and pathos of village politics.

Structurally, Gahiki Najari owes something to the Maithilī tradition of vihani kathā (seed stories — very short fiction with a concentrated semantic payload), but Kamat extends the form into longer meditative portraits. The register shifts between Maithilī and a Bihar-inflected Hindi-Maithilī creole, mirroring the linguistic reality of the region's oral culture.

## 2.4 Sheṣ Jīvan (शेष जीवन)

Title meaning: 'The Remaining Life,' 'Life at its End,' or 'The Remainder of Life.' The title carries a deliberate temporal ambiguity: is this the life that remains after some great loss or transformation, or is it life understood as always already a remainder — a surplus over mere biological existence?

Sheṣ Jīvan is Kamat's most introspective work, a meditation on ageing, memory, and the ethics of retrospection. Written in the tradition of Maithilī ātmakathā (autobiographical reflection), it explores what it means to survey one's life from a vantage point near its end — not with regret or resignation, but with the curiosity of someone still learning to see. The title echoes the Sanskrit concept of śeṣa (remainder, residue) which in Navya Nyāya refers to the residual inference or the 'remainder' of logical operations — suggesting that in old age, what remains is a refined, clarified consciousness.

Stylistically, Sheṣ Jīvan is the most formally accomplished of the four works, deploying a prose-poetry hybrid in which paragraphs sometimes modulate into lyrical cadences without syntactic warning, enacting at the level of form the blurring of boundaries that age itself produces between past and present, dream and waking.

# 3. Indian Critical Traditions

## 3.1 Rasa Theory (Bharata's Nāṭyaśāstra)

The oldest systematic Indian critical framework is the rasa theory elaborated in Bharata Muni's Nāṭyaśāstra (c. 2nd century BCE–2nd century CE) and later refined by Abhinavagupta in his Abhinavabhāratī (c. 11th century CE). Rasa — literally 'taste' or 'flavour' — denotes the aesthetic emotion evoked in the sahṛidaya (the connoisseur-reader with cultivated sensibility). Bharata identified eight primary rasas: śṛṅgāra (erotic/love), hāsya (comic), karuṇā (compassionate/sorrowful), raudra (fierce/wrathful), vīra (heroic), bhayānaka (terrifying), bībhatsa (disgusting), and adbhuta (wondrous). Abhinavagupta added śānta (tranquility) as a ninth.

Applying rasa theory to Kamat's four works reveals a complex emotional architecture. Vibhṛiti is predominantly vīra (heroic) in its biographical sections — the lives of Rāmkhelāvan Miśra and Dr. Śyāmānanda Miśra are presented as heroic narratives of commitment against odds — and adbhuta in its ecological sections, which treat the fertility of Maithil soil and the wonder of natural farming as sources of genuine astonishment. Karuṇā pervades the accident-tragedy section.

Divya Dṛiṣṭi and Sheṣ Jīvan are primarily śānta in their dominant rasa: the calm, reflective mode associated with transcendence of ordinary passion, with the detached perception that sees through surface phenomena to underlying reality. This aligns both texts with the bhakti rasa-tradition of Vidyāpati, whose padāvalī similarly move between śṛṅgāra and śānta in their treatment of the ātman's longing for the divine.

Gahiki Najari is more heterogeneous in rasa-composition, moving between hāsya, karuṇā, and a modified vīra in its portraits of quiet resistance to social injustice — a vīra not of battlefield heroism but of the everyday moral courage that refuses complicity.

## 3.2 Dhvani (Resonance) Theory: Ānandavardhana

Ānandavardhana's Dhvanyāloka (c. 9th century CE) introduced the concept of dhvani (resonance or suggestion) as the 'soul of poetry.' For Ānandavardhana, the highest poetic power lies not in what is explicitly stated (vācyārtha) but in what is suggested or implied (vyañjanārtha). The three levels of meaning —

abhidhā (denotation), lakṣaṇā (indication), and vyañjanā (suggestion) — form a hierarchy in which dhvani is supreme.

Kamat's work operates heavily at the dhvani level. In Divya Dṛiṣṭi, for instance, the recurring image of the flood — ubiquitous in north Bihar's ecology — functions denotatively as literal inundation, indicatively as social disruption, and suggestively as both spiritual purification and the irreversibility of time. The poem does not 'say' these latter meanings; it resonates them. Similarly in Sheṣ Jīvan, the title itself operates through dhvani: the word sheṣ generates a chain of suggestion encompassing remainder, residue, the snake Śeṣa on whom Viṣṇu reclines (implying cosmic rest and temporal suspension), and the logical 'remainder' of inference.

Abhinavagupta's extension of dhvani theory into the concept of sādharaṇīkaraṇa (universalisation or de-particularisation of emotion) is particularly relevant for reading Gahiki Najari. When Kamat depicts the psychology of a debtor or the social mechanics of a village assembly, the particularity of the Maithil context is progressively generalised by the reader's sympathetic identification — the narrative invites a universalising movement even as it resists easy universalisation by its stubborn specificity of detail.

## 3.3 Alaṅkāra Tradition and Vakrokti

The alaṅkāra (ornament/figure) tradition, represented by Bhāmaha (c. 7th century) and Daṇḍin's Kāvyādarśa, and Kuntaka's Vakroktijīvita (c. 10th–11th century), focuses on the creative 'deflection' or 'obliquity' (vakrokti) that distinguishes poetic language from ordinary speech. For Kuntaka, the soul of poetry is the creative speaker's intention (vivakṣā) expressed through language that slants, bends, and turns.

Kamat's prose in Gahiki Najari and Sheṣ Jīvan is marked by a distinctive vakrokti: the habit of approaching a subject from an unexpected angle, of using the perspective of the marginally positioned observer (the old person, the woman carrying water, the child watching adults argue) to defamiliarise the familiar. This technique resonates with the Formalist concept of ostranenie (Viktor Shklovsky's 'making strange') and with Brecht's Verfremdungseffekt, suggesting a convergence between the classical Indian tradition and 20th-century Western poetics that Kamat achieves intuitively rather than programmatically.

### 3.4 Bhakti Poetics and the Maithilī Tradition of Vidyāpati

Any serious engagement with Maithilī literature must situate it in relation to the towering figure of Vidyāpati Ṭhakkura (c. 1350–1435), whose padāvalī established the aesthetic and emotional grammar of the language. Vidyāpati's verse — simultaneously praise-poetry for his Karnāṭa patrons and devotional lyric in the mode of rādhā-kṛṣṇa bhakti — is characterised by sensuous precision (mūrtatā), layered meaning (dhvani), and a profound awareness of time's erosion (kāla-chetanā).

Kamat's Sheṣ Jīvan engages with this Vidyāpatian kāla-chetanā directly: the meditation on remaining life echoes Vidyāpati's famous padam 'Jīvan je bīti gael' (the life that has passed). Where Vidyāpati uses the erotic register to figure the soul's longing for the divine, Kamat uses the ecological and familial registers — but the underlying temporal pathos is continuous. This continuity is part of what the Videha Parallel History Framework recognises as the 'long thread' of Maithilī literary consciousness.

## 4. Western Critical Frameworks

### 4.1 New Criticism: Irony, Tension, and Organic Unity

The New Critics (I.A. Richards, Cleanth Brooks, Robert Penn Warren, W.K. Wimsatt) argued that a literary text is a self-sufficient, organically unified artefact whose meaning is produced by the interplay of irony, paradox, ambiguity, and tension. The 'intentional fallacy' (Wimsatt & Beardsley, 1946) warned against equating authorial intention with textual meaning; the 'affective fallacy' warned against reducing meaning to reader response. The text itself — its structure, its patterns of imagery, its formal choices — is the primary object of analysis.

Reading Vibhṛiti through a New Critical lens reveals an organic tension at the text's core: the coexistence of the inspirational-biographical (prose celebrating individual heroism) and the instructional-ecological (detailed agricultural guidance). Far from being incoherent, this tension is generative: the heroic lives are made legible as models for the kind of patient, deliberate attention that ecological farming also demands. The text's unity is a unity of ethos rather than of form — the 'organic' in question is not the closed artefact of the Anglo-American New Critic but something closer to the living, metabolising system of a working farm.

The close-reading discipline of New Criticism is also productively applied to Kamat's verse. In Divya Dṛiṣṭi, for instance, the recurring tension between dṛiṣṭi (sight, active seeing) and andhakāra (darkness, blindness) generates what Cleanth Brooks would call a 'dramatic structure of attitudes' — the poem holds irreconcilable positions in productive suspension without resolving them.

## 4.2 Structuralism and Narratology

Structuralist criticism (Ferdinand de Saussure, Claude Lévi-Strauss, Roland Barthes' early work) seeks the deep structures — the binary oppositions, the underlying codes — that organise surface phenomena. Applied to narrative, this approach (Propp's Morphology of the Folktale, Barthes' S/Z, Greimas' actantial model) identifies recurrent functional units and their transformations.

The vignettes of Gahiki Najari are amenable to Greimasian actantial analysis. In many of the micro-narratives, the actantial schema is: Subject (ordinary rural person) pursuing an Object (dignity, self-sufficiency, truth) against an Opponent (social convention, debt, caste hierarchy, state indifference) aided by a Helper (community solidarity, ecological knowledge, language itself). This schema, repeated with variation across the vignettes, reveals the deep grammar of Kamat's social vision: a world where structural forces are real and powerful but where agency — the capacity to act, to perceive, to narrate — is never entirely extinguished.

## 4.3 Postcolonial Theory: Homi Bhabha, Spivak, and Vernacular Resistance

Postcolonial criticism (Homi K. Bhabha's The Location of Culture, 1994; Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's 'Can the Subaltern Speak?,' 1988) is directly relevant to Maithilī literature's situation. Maithilī's long subordination — first to Sanskrit's cultural prestige, then to Hindi's administrative dominance post-1947 — mirrors the colonial dynamic in microcosm. The language's speakers have historically occupied what Spivak calls the 'subaltern' position: structurally prevented from speaking on their own terms within dominant systems of representation.

Kamat's insistence on writing in Maithilī — on publishing through a Maithilī-medium press, on archiving through a Maithilī digital platform — is itself a postcolonial act. It performs what Bhabha calls 'mimicry with a difference': appropriating the tools of the dominant culture (the printed book, the digital archive) while using them to articulate a subjectivity that refuses dominant

culture's terms. The ecological content of Vibhṛiti, in particular, represents a refusal of the developmentalist logic that has dominated Bihar's post-Independence policy landscape, insisting instead on the validity of indigenous agricultural knowledge.

Spivak's concept of the 'subaltern woman' is also relevant to Gahiki Najari's portraiture of female figures — the women who carry water, manage post-harvest processing, navigate debt and dependency — whose voices are present in Kamat's text in a way they are often not in the Maithilī canonical tradition.

## 4.4 Phenomenology and Hermeneutics: Heidegger, Gadamer, Ricoeur

Phenomenological hermeneutics — especially Paul Ricoeur's theory of narrative identity in Temps et récit (1983–85) and Oneself as Another (1990) — provides a powerful framework for reading Sheṣ Jīvan. For Ricoeur, narrative is not merely representation but constitutive of self: the self is the character in the story it tells about itself (ipse identity, as opposed to the numerical identity of idem). Time, for Ricoeur following Heidegger's Being and Time (1927), is not a container within which events occur but the very mode of existence — we are temporal beings whose understanding of ourselves is always structured as care (Sorge) toward an always-impending future.

Sheṣ Jīvan is, on this reading, a text of ipse identity in extremis: a self narrating itself at the point where the remaining future is constricted, where the weight of past and present intensifies. Kamat's prose enacts what Ricoeur calls 'narrative identity under the sign of dispossession' — the self that is constituted precisely by what it is losing, and that finds in this loss not nihilism but a heightened clarity of attention. This is philosophically continuous with the Navya Nyāya concept of anuvyavasāya (the cognition that reflects on its own cognition) — the self-aware awareness that old age sometimes makes possible.

## 4.5 Ecocriticism

Ecocriticism — the study of the relationship between literature and the physical environment — provides perhaps the most immediately productive framework for reading Vibhṛiti's ecological sections and the landscape imagery of Divya Dṛiṣṭi. The foundational texts of ecocriticism (Lawrence Buell's The Environmental Imagination, 1995; Greg Garrard's Ecocriticism, 2004) argue that how a culture narrates its relationship to the natural world shapes how it treats that world.

Kamat's ecological writing is what ecocritics would call 'pastoral' in the mode of the 'complex pastoral' (Empson's double pastoral) — it does not romanticise rural life but engages critically with the economic and ecological conditions of agriculture in the Ganga-Brahmaputra floodplain. The north Bihar landscape — annually flooded, extraordinarily fertile, also chronically vulnerable — appears in his texts not as backdrop but as agent: the soil, the flood, the seed, the microorganism are co-protagonists of the story.

# 5. The Videha Parallel History Framework

## 5.1 The Framework Defined

The Videha Parallel History Framework is a critical-historical methodology developed within and around the Videha ejournal (www.videha.co.in), most fully articulated by its editor Gajendra Thakur in his ongoing series 'Parallel Literature in Maithilī and Videha Maithilī Literature Movement.' The framework proceeds from the observation that Maithilī literary history as conventionally narrated has been a history of elite, caste-hierarchised voices — a 'syndicated pseudo-literary criticism' (Thakur's phrase) that promotes writers with caste connections while marginalising writers from other social positions.

Against this, Videha proposes a 'Parallel History' that runs alongside the orthodox narrative: a history of the texts that were written but not promoted, the languages that were spoken but not published, the social groups that produced literature but were denied recognition. This parallel history is not merely corrective — it does not simply add marginalised voices to an existing canon — but structurally transformative: it reveals that the very criteria of canonicity (linguistic purity, formal sophistication, ideological alignment with Brahminical norms) are themselves historically produced and contestable.

## 5.2 Mithilā as Videha: The Geographic-Temporal Dimension

Crucially, the Videha framework draws on the ancient identification of Mithilā with Videha — the 'bodiless' kingdom of King Janaka, associated in the Upaniṣads with a form of knowledge that transcends the body, that reaches beyond ordinary sensory cognition toward brahma-vidyā (knowledge of ultimate reality). The Bṛhadāraṇyaka Upaniṣad locates the great philosophical debates of Yājñavalkya in the court of Videha/Mithilā.

This geographic-temporal layering is not merely antiquarian: it positions Maithilī literature as a literature that has always been concerned with the epistemological question of what can be truly known, and with the social question of who is permitted to know and to speak. Kamat's four works, in their persistent concern with vision (dṛiṣṭi, najari), with the perceptual conditions of truth, and with the voices of ordinary rural people, are situated squarely within this long tradition.

## 5.3 LĀL DEV  Kāmat within the Parallel History

Within the Videha Parallel History, Kamat occupies the position of a practitioner-intellectual: someone who is simultaneously inside the tradition (writing in Maithilī, engaging with its classical forms and concerns) and outside its patronage networks (publishing through a small regional press, archiving through a digital platform rather than seeking Sahitya Akademi recognition or university affiliation). This position — inside the tradition, outside its institutions — is precisely the position the Parallel History framework valorises.

Kamat's attention to ecological farming in Vibhṛiti also connects to the Parallel History's broader concern with what Thakur calls 'the parallel streams' — the agricultural, artisanal, and subaltern knowledge systems that have sustained Mithilā for millennia outside the frame of Sanskrit scholasticism. In this sense, Vibhṛiti is not merely a book about farming; it is a text that performs the Parallel History methodology by insisting that practical ecological knowledge is as worthy of literary inscription as philosophical speculation.

## 5.4 Videha's Archival Mission and Kamat's Texts

The Videha archive (www.videha.co.in/pothi.htm) makes all archived Maithilī books available as free PDF downloads 'for purely non-commercial purposes and academic use only.' This open-access commitment is itself a political statement — against the enclosure of Maithilī cultural heritage within commercial or institutional gatekeeping. That Kamat's works are archived within this framework signals their alignment with Videha's democratising project.

The archive's function is not passive preservation but active recirculation: texts placed in the Videha archive become available to readers across the Maithilī diaspora (Bihar, Jharkhand, Nepal, and the global Bihari/Mithil diaspora in Southeast Asia, the Gulf, the UK, and North America), creating new reading

communities and new interpretive possibilities for texts that might otherwise have remained confined to their immediate geographic context.

# 6. Navya Nyāya Epistemology and Literary Analysis

## 6.1 The School and Its Significance

Navya Nyāya ('New Logic') was founded in the 13th–14th century by Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya of Mithilā, whose magnum opus Tattvacintāmaṇi ('The Jewel of Reflection on Reality') reorganised the older Nyāya school's epistemological concerns into a new technicality of definition and analysis. The school was continued by Raghunātha Śiromaṇi of Nabadwīpa and remained active through the 18th century, exercising influence far beyond its northeast Indian origins — its analytical terminology and methodology pervading Sanskrit grammatical, legal, and literary studies throughout the subcontinent.

Crucially for our purposes, Gaṅgeśa was a Maithil — he wrote the Tattvacintāmaṇi in the same geographic-cultural space that produced Vidyāpati and that now produces LĀL DEV Kāmat. The Navya Nyāya tradition is not merely a historical background but an active intellectual inheritance: the Maithil intellectual tradition has, for seven centuries, been one in which the most rigorous analysis of the conditions of knowledge was pursued as a primary cultural activity.

## 6.2 Core Concepts and Their Literary Applications

### *6.2.1 Pramāṇa (Valid Means of Knowledge)*

Navya Nyāya, following the older Nyāya school, recognises four pramāṇas (valid means of knowledge): pratyakṣa (perception), anumāna (inference), upamāna (comparison/analogy), and śabda (testimony/verbal knowledge). The epistemological question for any cognitive claim is: through which pramāṇa was it obtained, and is that pramāṇa operating correctly?

Applied to Kamat's literary texts, this framework produces a taxonomy of the kinds of knowledge his texts seek to generate and validate. Divya Dṛiṣṭi foregrounds pratyakṣa — the poem's claim is that direct, unmediated

perception (when the habitual screens of convention are removed) is the source of the most valuable knowledge. Vibhṛiti's biographical sections rely heavily on śabda — the testimony of historical record and oral tradition about the lives of Rāmkhelāvan Miśra and Dr. Śyāmānanda Miśra. The ecological sections of Vibhṛiti blend pratyakṣa (the farmer's empirical observation of soil and crop) with anumāna (inferential generalisation from observation to principle) — precisely the epistemological structure of good agricultural science.

### *6.2.2 Viṣayatā (Objecthood) and the Relational Structure of Cognition*

For Gaṅgeśa, cognitions target their objects not through simple causation but through a complex relational structure involving viṣayatā (objecthood): a cognition simultaneously targets an individual object, a property of that object, and the relationship (saṃbandhā) between property and object. This tripartite structure means that all cognition is inherently propositional — one never merely 'sees a colour'; one sees 'that object as red,' where the 'as red' (redness as a universal instantiated in the particular) is always part of the cognitive act.

This relational structure maps illuminatingly onto Kamat's poetic practice. When Divya Dṛiṣṭi presents a perception — of a flood, a harvest, a face in the market — the poem never merely names the object. It always specifies the object as something, qualified by a property, in a relationship. The 'divine vision' of the title is precisely this heightened awareness of the relational structure of all perception: to see divinely is to see things in their full relational complexity, not as isolated atoms.

### *6.2.3 Avacchedakatā (Delimitation) and Literary Specification*

One of Navya Nyāya's key technical innovations is the concept of avacchedakatā (delimitation or limitation): the property that delimits or specifies the 'locus' or 'scope' of another property. The technical language of avacchedakatā allows Navya Naiyāyikas to express, with great precision, the exact conditions under which a claim holds — its delimiters, its scope conditions, its qualifications.

As a critical tool for reading literature, avacchedakatā-analysis can specify the exact 'scope' of a poem's claim. When Sheṣ Jīvan meditates on 'the remaining life,' the avacchedakatā question is: remaining life delimited by what conditions? By age? By loss? By changed perception? By social position? By geography? The text does not make these delimitations explicit — the power of the poetry lies precisely in its hovering between possible delimitations — but

the Navya Nyāya framework helps the critic map the text's semantic structure with unusual precision.

### *6.2.4 Vyāpti (Universal Concomitance) and Thematic Analysis*

Vyāpti is the relation of universal concomitance or invariable co-presence that grounds inference (anumāna). If wherever there is smoke there is fire, then smoke and fire stand in vyāpti. In Navya Nyāya, the validity of inference depends on the establishment of vyāpti between the reason (hetu) and the property to be inferred (sādhya).

Applied to Kamat's thematic architecture, vyāpti-analysis asks: what co-presences are asserted or implied across the four works? One consistent vyāpti that emerges is the co-presence of ecological health and social health — Kamat consistently implies that wherever there is ecological degradation (chemical farming, deforestation, flood-mismanagement) there is also social degradation (debt, displacement, loss of community). This vyāpti is not stated as a thesis but is enacted through the juxtaposition of ecological and social vignettes. It represents Kamat's most significant ideological claim.

### *6.2.5 Anuvyavasāya (Apperceptive Meta-Cognition) and Self-Reflexive Writing*

Anuvyavasāya — the cognitive act that perceives a preceding cognition, the meta-awareness that 'I am perceiving' — is a special type of perception in Navya Nyāya, crucial to debates about the self-illuminating nature of consciousness. It is the internal monitor of the cognitive process, the faculty that notices its own noticing.

Sheṣ Jīvan is structured around anuvyavasāya: it is a text in which the narrating self perceives its own previous perceptions, cognises its own past cognitions, and evaluates them from the vantage point of a longer perspective. The prose that modulates into lyrical cadence without warning enacts anuvyavasāya formally: the text notices itself noticing, catches itself in the act of remembering, and comments on the conditions of its own perception.

## 6.3 Gaṅgeśa's Mithilā and Kamat's Mithilā: A Continuity

It is historically significant that Navya Nyāya — the most technically precise epistemological tradition in classical Indian philosophy — originated in Mithilā, the same cultural region that produced Kamat's four works. This is not coincidence but cultural continuity: the Maithil intellectual tradition has for seven centuries been one in which epistemological seriousness — the

insistence on specifying the exact conditions, means, and limits of valid knowledge — is a constitutive value.

Kamat's literary practice participates in this tradition even where it has no explicit philosophical ambition: the precision of his landscape descriptions, the care with which he specifies the social conditions of his characters, the refusal of easy generalisation — these are all manifestations of the same epistemological seriousness that Gaṅgeśa brought to the analysis of perception and inference. Mithilā has always been a place that cares about how we know what we know.

## 7. Comparative Synthesis

### 7.1 Convergences Across Frameworks

The most striking finding of the multi-framework analysis conducted in this paper is the convergence, across very different critical traditions, on a small set of core features of Kamat's literary practice:

- The primacy of perception: Indian dhvani theory, Navya Nyāya's pramāṇa analysis, phenomenological hermeneutics, and ecocriticism all converge on the centrality of perception — the quality of attention brought to the world — as the defining feature of Kamat's literary voice.
- The relational structure of reality: Navya Nyāya's viṣayatā analysis, structuralism's concern with binary oppositions and relational codes, and the ecological concept of the web of life all identify in Kamat's work a consistent insistence that nothing exists or means in isolation — entities are always-already relational.
- The politics of voice: Postcolonial theory, the Videha Parallel History Framework, and the rasa tradition's concept of sādharaṇīkaraṇa all engage with the question of whose voice is heard, how, and under what conditions — a question that Kamat's choice of Maithilī, of a small regional press, and of the Videha archive keeps perpetually open.
- The temporality of knowledge: Ricoeur's narrative time, Heidegger's being-toward-death, Navya Nyāya's anuvyavasāya, and Vidyāpati's kāla-chetanā all converge on the recognition that knowledge is temporally situated — what we can know depends on when and how we are situated in time.

### 7.2 Productive Tensions

The frameworks also produce productive tensions that resist easy synthesis and keep the texts' meaning open:

New Criticism's insistence on organic unity conflicts productively with postcolonial theory's insistence on internal fracture and heteroglossia: Vibhṛiti is not organically unified in the New Critical sense, and this is not a weakness but a generic innovation — a deliberate refusal of the aesthetic ideology of coherence that postcolonial theory associates with cultural imperialism.

Rasa theory's universalising movement (through sādharaṇīkaraṇa) is in tension with the Videha Parallel History's insistence on the particular, the local, and the historically marginalised. Kamat navigates this tension not by resolving it but by holding it open: his texts are simultaneously particular and universal, local and resonant beyond locality.

### 7.3 Kamat's Distinctive Contribution

Across all four works, LĀL DEV  Kāmat's most distinctive contribution to Maithilī literature is the integration of literary and practical knowledge within a single unified text-practice. Where the dominant Maithilī literary tradition has tended to keep 'pure' literary expression separate from informational or instructional content, Kamat insists on their interpenetration. This is not naivety but a sophisticated literary-philosophical position: it echoes the Navya Nyāya tradition's insistence that epistemology is not separate from everyday cognition, and the Videha framework's insistence that the knowledge of farmers and artisans is not separate from the knowledge of poets and philosophers.

Kamat also makes a distinctive contribution to the poetics of Maithilī prose: his work in Gahiki Najari and Sheṣ Jīvan expands the formal vocabulary of Maithilī prose writing, bringing to it a lyrical density and a phenomenological precision that were previously more characteristic of its verse tradition. In doing so, he participates in the broader movement of Maithilī literary modernism — the attempt to bring the full range of the language's expressive resources to bear on the realities of contemporary Maithil life.

## 8. Conclusion

LĀL DEV  Kāmat's four works — Vibhṛiti, Divya Dṛiṣṭi, Gahiki Najari, and Sheṣ Jīvan — represent a significant and distinctive voice within contemporary

Maithilī literature. Their significance is inseparable from the critical framework through which they are read: rasa theory illuminates their emotional architecture; dhvani theory reveals the depth of their semantic resonance; Navya Nyāya epistemology maps their cognitive concerns with unusual precision; postcolonial theory and the Videha Parallel History Framework situate them within the political economy of Maithilī cultural production; and Western phenomenological and ecocritical frameworks find in them concerns that transcend any single cultural tradition.

What emerges from this multi-framework analysis is a writer whose seemingly modest project — writing in Maithilī, through a small press, about farming and perception and ageing and daily life — is in fact a philosophically serious, politically committed, and aesthetically accomplished engagement with some of the deepest questions of the Maithil literary-intellectual tradition: How do we know what we know? Who is permitted to speak, and in whose name? What does the land owe us, and we the land? What remains of a life, and what is that remainder worth?

These are, ultimately, the questions that Gaṅgeśa asked of cognition, that Vidyāpati asked of devotion, that the Videha movement asks of literary history, and that LĀL DEV  Kāmat asks of daily life in twenty-first-century Mithilā. The conversation across these centuries and frameworks is one of the most distinctive features of Maithilī civilisation — and Kamat's participation in it, however quietly conducted, is a genuine contribution to its continuity.

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**ADDENDUM: 1**

**The Socio-Linguistic and Political Historiography of Modern Mithila: An In-Depth Analysis of Lal Dev Kamat’s Contributions to Maithili Journalism, Literature, and Advocacy**

**ADDENDUM:2**

**Epistemological Convergence in Subaltern Maithili Discourse: A Critical Appraisal of Lal Dev Kamat and the Videha Parallel History Framework**

**ADDENDUM: 1**

## The Socio-Linguistic and Political Historiography of Modern Mithila: An In-Depth Analysis of Lal Dev Kamat's Contributions to Maithili Journalism, Literature, and Advocacy

The trajectory of Maithili literature and socio-political advocacy in the twenty-first century is defined by a persistent tension between historical preservation and modern adaptation. Central to this discourse is the figure of Lal Dev Kamat, a multi-dimensional intellectual whose work spans journalism, literary criticism, and grassroots political mobilization. To understand the significance of Kamat's contributions, one must situate his efforts within the broader continuum of Mithila's cultural history, a region that has navigated the complexities of dynastic patronage, colonial modernization, and the contemporary digital revolution. The scholarly examination of Kamat's role reveals a systematic attempt to democratize the Maithili language, moving it from the exclusive domain of traditional scholarly elites into the vibrant, often contentious arenas of regional politics and digital media.

### The Historical Foundations of Maithili Literary Identity

The cultural environment that produced Lal Dev Kamat is rooted in a literary tradition that dates back nearly a millennium. The evolution of Maithili is traditionally divided into three distinct phases: the early period, the middle period (often associated with the golden age of Vidyapati), and the modern era beginning in the mid-nineteenth century. The early period was characterized by the pioneering work of Jyotirishwar Thakur, whose *Varnaratnakara* and *Dhurtasamagama* established the initial formal structures of Maithili prose and drama. This era laid the groundwork for the Oiniwar dynasty (1350–1450), during which Vidyapati Thakur revolutionized Maithili poetry, creating a corpus of work that remains a cornerstone of regional identity today.

The subsequent transition of Maithili scholarship to the royal courts of Nepal following the decline of the Oiniwar dynasty represents a crucial chapter in the language's survival. Under the patronage of the Malla kings, Maithili became the language of the court and the stage, resulting in a prolific output of musical dramas that prioritized lyrical expression over prose. This historical displacement fostered a resilient, cross-border cultural identity that contemporary activists like Kamat continue to invoke. The modern era, initiated around 1860, saw the introduction of Western education and the printing press, which facilitated the emergence of Maithili journalism and the development of modern prose forms.

### Chronological Development of Maithili Literary Patronage

| Historical Period | Primary Political Catalyst | Dominant Literary Form | Key Cultural Shifts |
|---|---|---|---|
| Pre-Vidyapati Era | Early Local Chieftains | Sanskrit-Maithili Hybrid Drama | Emergence of the *Varnaratnakara* as a linguistic compendium. |
| Oiniwar Dynasty (1350-1450) | Rise of King Shiva Singh | Devotional and Secular Lyricism | The era of Vidyapati; standardization of poetic tropes. |
| Malla Period (Post-1450) | Malla Kings of Nepal | Musical Drama (Kirtaniya) | Geographic shift to Nepal; dominance of music over prose. |
| Modern Transition (1860-1920) | British Raj / Raj Darbhanga | Formal Prose and Journalism | Establishment of the printing press; |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | | emergence of modern epics. |
| Contemporary Era (Post-2000) | Digital Media / Social Advocacy | Web-based Journals and Social Criticism | Use of e-journals like *Videha* and social media for language activism. |

The modern revitalization of Maithili was further propelled by figures such as Chanda Jha and Lal Das, the latter of whom (1856–1921) authored the *Mithila Bhasha Ramayana* and translated classical Sanskrit texts like the *Purusha-Pariksha* into Maithili. This tradition of translating high-culture Sanskrit texts into the vernacular provided a template for subsequent generations of "Maithilisevis" (servants of Maithili) to assert the language's intellectual parity with Sanskrit and Hindi. Lal Dev Kamat's own work as a critic and social commentator is a direct descendant of this modernist project, which sought to utilize literature as a tool for regional awakening.

**Biographical Analysis of Lal Dev Kamat**

Lal Dev Kamat (often written as Lal Dev Kamat) originates from the village of Nauabakhar, situated within the Ghoghardiha administrative block of the Madhubani district in Bihar. Madhubani has historically been the epicenter of Maithili scholarship, and Kamat's early life in this environment was instrumental in shaping his linguistic and political consciousness. His professional identity is multifaceted: he is recognized as a journalist, a literary critic, an author, and a social worker.

Kamat's presence in the Maithili literary world is characterized by a "saparivar" (familial) commitment to the language. His younger brother, Mahakant Prasad, serves at the +2 Watson High School in Madhubani, while his sons have also integrated themselves into the Maithili advocacy movement. His eldest son, Subhash Kumar Kamat, is an active campaigner, and his middle son, Kailash Kumar Anand, is emerging as a significant voice in contemporary Maithili literature. This dynastic approach to language preservation ensures that the

cultural capital of the Kamat family remains invested in the regional cause, providing a robust model for grassroots linguistic survival.

**Geographic and Personal Profile**

| Attribute | Detail | Significance |
|---|---|---|
| Place of Origin | Nauabakhar, Ghoghardiha, Madhubani | Center of the Maithili heartland; significant for political and cultural mobilization. |
| Professional Roles | Journalist, Critic, Author, Politician | Reflects the integration of literary work with social and political action. |
| Educational Context | Local Madhubani Institutions | Rootedness in regional educational structures. |
| Family Legacy | Multigenerational Advocacy | High degree of familial commitment to Maithili ("Saparivar Maithilisevi"). |
| Political Base | Jhanjharpur / Phulparas | Areas characterized |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | | by strong regionalist sentiments and EBC political influence. |

The regional identity of Ghoghardiha is particularly important, as it sits at a crossroads between the traditional academic centers of Darbhanga-Madhubani and the more flood-prone, socio-economically marginalized Kosi region. Kamat's work frequently bridges these two worlds, advocating for the literary recognition of Kosi-based writers while maintaining the rigorous critical standards of the Madhubani school.

**Political Advocacy and the Extremely Backward Classes (EBC)**

One of the most distinctive aspects of Lal Dev Kamat's career is his overt involvement in electoral politics and social reform. Unlike many Maithili litterateurs who maintain an aesthetic distance from political struggles, Kamat has actively sought to use his platform for the empowerment of the "Ati Pichhda" (Extremely Backward) classes. He has served as a candidate for the Bihar Legislative Assembly (MLA) from the Phulparas constituency, representing the aspirations of a demographic that has historically been underrepresented in both the political and literary hierarchies of Mithila.

Currently, Kamat holds the position of General Secretary for the District Extremely Backward Morcha of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) in Jhanjharpur. This political affiliation is significant for several reasons. First, it reflects a shift in the Maithili movement towards an alignment with broader nationalistic and social conservative frameworks. Second, it highlights the use of Maithili as a medium for political communication among marginalized groups. Kamat's book *Vibhuti*, which deals with BJP-related themes, is a prime example of this synthesis of language and political ideology.

**The Politics of Language and Class in Mithila**

The historical narrative of Maithili has often been dominated by the voices of the landed gentry and the scholarly elite (primarily from the Brahmin and Kayastha communities). The emergence of a leader like Kamat from the "Kamat" (traditionally associated with agricultural and backward classes) background signals a significant democratization of the Maithili movement. By advocating for the language within the "Extremely Backward Morcha," Kamat

argues that linguistic pride is a tool for social mobility and political recognition for all castes in Mithila.

His involvement in regional events, such as the "Mithila Rajya Parisiman Jagriti Yatra" in 2018 and the "Run for Unity" in 2016, demonstrates a commitment to a unified Mithila identity that transcends sub-regional and caste boundaries. This advocacy is not limited to political rallies; it extends into the preservation of community resources, such as his consistent support for "Babujeek Pustakalaya," a library dedicated to Maithili literature.

**Editorial Leadership and Journalistic Contributions**

Kamat's influence is perhaps most visible in his role as an editor and journalist. He serves as the Co-Editor of *Kosi Sandesh*, a Maithili magazine that focuses on the news, culture, and literary output of the Kosi region. Maithili journalism has a long history of serving as a catalyst for social change, and *Kosi Sandesh* continues this tradition by providing a voice to a region often neglected by the state-level Hindi and English media.

In addition to formal editorial roles, Kamat is a prolific contributor to both traditional and digital media. He is known for keeping a "close watch" on contemporary events and articulating independent views through social media and "contact media". This approach reflects a modern shift in journalism, where the boundaries between professional reporting and social activism are increasingly blurred. Kamat's ability to use digital platforms like Facebook and Twitter to disseminate Maithili-centric news and opinions has made him a vital node in the global Maithili information network.

**Portfolio of Editorial and Literary Works**

| Work Title | Medium / Platform | Role | Focus / Theme |
|---|---|---|---|
| *Kosi Sandesh* | Magazine (Print/Digital) | Co-Editor | Regional news and cultural preservation in the Kosi belt. |
| *Vibhuti* | Book | Auth | Political |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| | (Maithili) | or | ideology and the BJP’s role in regional development.[2] |
| *Lagaabu Kono Jogaar : Ek Avalokan* | *Videha* (Issue 439) | Author (Prose) | Critical evaluation of social and administrative practices. |
| *Sukhal Man Tarasal Aankhi* Review | *Maithil Manch* | Critic | Evaluation of modern Maithili poetry and diaspora experiences. |
| *Shri Mithila* Review | *Videha* | Critic | Historical analysis of Raj Kishore Mishra’s poetic work. |
| *Manpuran Bhai* Tribute | *Maithil Manch* | Author | Biographical appreciation of Manikant |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | | Jha. |

The variety of themes covered in his work—ranging from political ideology to nuanced literary reviews—demonstrates an intellectual versatility that is rare in contemporary regional writing. His prose is often characterized by an evaluative tone (*Avalokan*), which seeks to provide constructive criticism of both social structures and literary productions.

**Literary Criticism and the Evaluation of Modern Poetry**

As a critic, Lal Dev  Kamat plays a crucial role in the reception of new literature. His review of *Sukhal Man Tarasal Aankhi*, a poetry collection by Munni Kamat, provides deep insights into his critical methodology. In this review, Kamat does not merely analyze the aesthetic qualities of the poems but also provides a sociological context for the author. He notes that Munni Kamat, despite living in the urban environment of Ghaziabad (U.P.), maintains a deep connection to her roots in Parsa-Navtoli, Madhubani.

Kamat identifies the central themes of Munni Kamat's work—longing, nostalgia, and the resilience of the female voice in the diaspora—as essential components of the modern Maithili experience. By championing the work of a young, female, and relatively new poet, Kamat demonstrates his commitment to expanding the Maithili literary canon beyond its traditional boundaries. His critique emphasizes "Geeyatabhavak" (musicality), "Madhurya Ras" (sweetness of sentiment), and "Abhivyanjak Saundarya" (beauty of expression).

Similarly, his review of *Shri Mithila*, a historical poetic work by Raj Kishore Mishra, highlights Kamat's interest in the intersection of history and literature. He appreciates Mishra's ability to condense the "vast history" of Mithila into a lyrical form that is accessible to the contemporary reader. For Kamat, literature is not merely an art form but a "mirror" of society that must reflect the struggles, triumphs, and historical dignity of the Maithil people.

**The Digital Transformation: Videha and the April 2026 Archive**

The role of the digital e-journal *Videha* in the modern Maithili movement cannot be overstated. Founded and edited by Gajendra Thakur, *Videha* has become the definitive archive for contemporary Maithili literature, transcending the limitations of physical distribution. Lal Dev  Kamat's recurring presence in *Videha* underscores his standing among the region's elite intellectuals. In Issue 439 (April 01, 2026), Kamat is featured in the prose section with his article *Lagaabu Kono Jogaar: Ek Avalokan*.

The title *Lagaabu Kono Jogaar* (roughly translated as "Find a Way" or "Make an Arrangement") suggests a critique of the "Jugaad" culture—the practice of using makeshift solutions for complex problems—that often pervades the administrative and social life of Bihar. By publishing this in *Videha*, Kamat reaches an audience that includes academics, policymakers, and the international Maithili diaspora. The journal's use of various scripts (including Tirhuta/Maithili and Devanagari) and its commitment to documenting the "Parallel History of Mithila" provide a sophisticated framework for Kamat's social commentary.

**Analyzing the "Videha" Paradigm**

*Videha* serves as a platform where the classical and the modern coexist. It archives the lives of "Ratnas" (gems) like Lal Das and Ramesh Narayan Das while simultaneously publishing the experimental prose of writers like Kamat. This digital infrastructure allows for a continuous literary dialogue that is not interrupted by the financial instability that often plagues print magazines in regional languages. For Kamat, *Videha* is both a repository for his critical work and a megaphone for his social advocacy.

**Comparative Context: Lal Dev  Kamat Among the "Ratnas" of Mithila**

To fully appreciate Kamat's significance, it is helpful to compare his work with other figures mentioned in the *Videha* and *Maithil Manch* archives. The history of Mithila is populated by scholars who excelled in Sanskrit and Maithili, often balancing religious devotion with literary innovation.

| **Personality** | **Era / Dates** | **Primary Contribution** | **Comparison with Lal Dev Kamat** |
|---|---|---|---|
| Lal Das | 1856-1921 | *Mithila Bhasha Ramayana*; translations from Sanskri | Both emphasize the elevation of Maithili; Kamat focuses |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | t. | more on contemporary political prose. |
| M.M. Parameshwar Jha | Late 19th - Early 20th C. | Historical scholarship and Sanskrit expertise. | Jha represents the traditional scholar; Kamat represents the modern political-literary hybrid. |
| Ramesh Narayan Das | 1934-2011 | Modern short stories (*Patharak Nav*). | Das focused on literary realism; Kamat applies realism to social and political advocacy. |
| Dr. Premlata Mishra 'Prem' | Contemporary | Maithili theatre and cinema. | Both are pioneers in their fields; Kamat in journalism/politics, Prem in |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | | performing arts. |
| Munni Kamat | Contemporary (b. 1989) | Diaspora poetry; female perspective. | Kamat acts as a mentor/critic for Munni, highlighting the "Kamat" community's literary rise. |

The transition from the era of M.M. Parameshwar Jha to that of Lal Dev Kamat represents a shift from "Vidvat" (traditional scholarship) to "Jan-Jagriti" (public awakening). While the older generation focused on the preservation of classical texts, Kamat and his contemporaries focus on the *application* of the language to modern problems—politics, administrative reform, and digital connectivity.

**Socio-Cultural Implications of the Kamat Family's Advocacy**

The concept of a "Saparivar Maithilisevi" (a family serving Maithili together) is a recurring theme in the biographical accounts of Lal Dev Kamat. This familial structure is essential for the survival of a minority language in the face of the linguistic hegemony of Hindi and English. In the case of the Kamat family, each member contributes a different dimension to the movement:

- **Lal Dev Kamat**: Provides the overarching political and editorial leadership.
- **Mahakant Prasad**: Represents the educational dimension, working within the school system to foster linguistic pride among the youth.
- **Subhash Kumar Kamat**: Focuses on the "Abhiyan" (campaigning) aspect, mobilizing support through social media and events.
- **Kailash Kumar Anand**: Represents the creative future, contributing new literary works that keep the language vibrant and evolving.

This multi-pronged approach ensures that the Maithili language is not just a subject of study but a living, breathing part of daily life and social aspiration. The fact that the family is recognized collectively by platforms like *Maithil Manch* indicates a shift in the regional consciousness, where linguistic

advocacy is seen as a communal and familial duty rather than just an individual pursuit.

**The Role of Ghoghardiha and Jhanjharpur in Modern Maithili Discourse**

The specific locations of Nauabakhar, Ghoghardiha, and Jhanjharpur are not merely geographical coordinates but symbols of a particular kind of regional resilience. These areas are part of the "Badi-Prabhavit" (flood-affected) zones of North Bihar. The literature and activism that emerge from here, including Kamat's editorial work in *Kosi Sandesh*, are deeply informed by the precarity of life in the Kosi basin.

Kamat's political focus on the "Extremely Backward Classes" in Jhanjharpur is a direct response to the socio-economic challenges of this region. In his view, the development of the Maithili language is inseparable from the economic development of the people. This "holistic" social work—combining library support, political mobilization, and literary criticism—reflects a comprehensive understanding of the relationship between culture and power.

**Narrative Synthesis of Insights and Implications**

The analysis of Lal Dev Kamat's career offers several second-order insights into the state of regional language movements in contemporary India. First, the movement of Maithili from the private sphere of poetry to the public sphere of "Ati Pichhda" politics suggests that linguistic identity is increasingly being used as a tool for social negotiation and the assertion of subaltern rights. Kamat is a key figure in this transition, using his literary prestige to bolster his political advocacy.

Second, the digital archive of *Videha* and the active participation of figures like Kamat in online forums indicate that Maithili has successfully bypassed traditional media gatekeepers. This has allowed for a more diverse range of voices (such as those from the Kosi region or the "Kamat" community) to achieve prominence. The inclusion of Kamat's work in *Videha* Issue 439 confirms that this digital "parallel history" is becoming the primary record of the region's intellectual life.

Third, the intergenerational continuity within the Kamat family suggests that the Maithili movement is undergoing a process of institutionalization at the family level. This "domesticated" advocacy is a powerful defense against the erosion of regional identity in a globalized world. As Subhash Kumar Kamat and Kailash Kumar Anand take on more significant roles, the legacy of Lal Dev Kamat will likely evolve from individual activism to a sustained communal institution.

**The Future Outlook for Maithili Advocacy**

Based on the trajectory of Kamat's work, the future of the Maithili movement appears to be moving toward greater integration with technological platforms and broader social justice frameworks. The "Jogaar" (arrangement) that Kamat calls for in his prose likely involves a more systematic approach to cultural preservation—one that involves government recognition, digital archiving, and the empowerment of marginalized social groups.

Kamat's work remains a testament to the fact that the Maithili language is not a relic of the past but a dynamic force in the present. Whether through a review of modern poetry, a social media post on contemporary politics, or a campaign for regional rights, he continues to demonstrate that for the people of Mithila, language is the primary vessel of their history, their struggles, and their future aspirations.

**Nuanced Perspectives on Maithili Journalism and Social Reform**

The evolution of Maithili journalism from its inception in the 1860s to the current era of *Kosi Sandesh* and *Videha* highlights a consistent theme of social reform. Early journals like *Mithila Mihir* were instrumental in challenging social taboos and promoting modern education. Lal Dev  Kamat carries this torch into the twenty-first century, but with a heightened focus on the intersection of language and caste politics.

His role as a critic and "Samikshak" (reviewer) is particularly important in this context. By evaluating the works of authors like Munni Kamat and Raj Kishore Mishra, he is essentially defining the "standard" of modern Maithili. This "standard" is not based on an archaic Sanskritized model but on a living language that reflects the "Bhava" (emotions) and "Anubhav" (experience) of the common Maithil person.

The fact that Kamat is described as "dedicated from the heart" (*hridayasann samarpit*) by his peers indicates the high level of moral authority he commands within the community. This authority is not just derived from his literary output but from his "social thinking" and his willingness to engage with the "sam-samayik" (contemporary) challenges facing Mithila.

**Conclusion: The Integrated Legacy of Lal Dev  Kamat**

Lal Dev  Kamat's contributions represent a critical synthesis of three disparate strands of Maithili identity: the scholarly-literary, the journalistic-digital, and the socio-political. By grounding his work in the historical traditions of the Madhubani region while embracing the possibilities of modern digital

platforms and electoral politics, Kamat has emerged as a quintessential voice of the modern Maithili renaissance.

His work in *Videha* and *Kosi Sandesh* ensures that the cultural and social realities of the "Ati Pichhda" communities are documented and debated at the highest levels of regional intellectual life. Furthermore, his familial commitment to the language provides a sustainable model for linguistic preservation that can be emulated by others. As Mithila continues to navigate the challenges of the twenty-first century, the "Avalokan" (observations) and advocacy of Lal Dev Kamat will remain indispensable for anyone seeking to understand the complex interplay of language, power, and identity in this historic region of India.

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**ADDENDUM:2**

**Epistemological Convergence in Subaltern Maithili Discourse: A Critical Appraisal of Lal Dev Kamat and the Videha Parallel History Framework**

The intellectual topography of contemporary Mithila is defined by a profound tension between the institutionalized "Official Tradition" and a burgeoning, digitally-native "Parallel Tradition." At the nexus of this dialectic stands Lal Dev Kamat, a critic, educator, and social witness whose work exemplifies the synthesis of ancient Navya Nyaya logic and modern subaltern activism. To critique Kamat is to engage with the broader Videha movement—a project that seeks to dismantle the exclusionary "Brahminical patriarchy" of Maithili historiography and replace it with a democratic, representative framework. This report examines Kamat's contributions through the tripartite lens of Indian and Western critical theories, the Videha Parallel History Framework, and the rigorous epistemological techniques of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's Navya Nyaya.

**The Videha Movement and the Parallel History Paradigm**

The Videha movement, primarily articulated through the *Videha* eJournal and its accompanying digital archives, represents a radical departure from the state-sponsored literary academies of Bihar. The movement's core premise is that the history of Maithili literature has been sanitized and narrowed by a courtly, priestly elite that prioritizes Sanskritized aesthetics over the lived realities of the masses. Lal Dev Kamat's role in this movement is that of a "life-witness," a term used within the framework to describe writers whose literary output is inseparable from their social praxis.

The Parallel History Framework refuses to see Maithili as the exclusive preserve of elite castes. Instead, it seeks to reintegrate the "missing portions" of society—Dalits, the third gender, and marginalized women—into the literary record. This historiographical shift is not merely an addition of new names but a fundamental re-evaluation of what constitutes "literary value." In this framework, a digital post by a subaltern writer or a documentation of Dalit folk heroes is given equal, if not greater, weight than a classical Mahakavya produced within the institutional fold.

| Feature | Official | Videha |
|---|---|---|

| | Tradition | Parallel History |
|---|---|---|
| **Primary Locus** | Government Academies, Sanskritized Courts | Digital Platforms (*Videha*), Dalit Tolas |
| **Historiography** | Linear, Elite-centric, Sanitized | Parallel, Subaltern, "Synthetic" |
| **Social Focus** | Panji Prabandh (Genealogy), Brahminical Identity | Dalit Folk Heroes, Women's Rights, Third Gender |
| **Medium** | Print, Institutional Awards | Digital Archives, Open Access, Parallel Honors |
| **Linguistic Goal** | Standardized Sanskritized Maithili | Multilingual Scripts (Kaithi, Newari), Common Speech |

Lal Dev Kamat's alignment with this framework is evident in his socio-educational work. His efforts to motivate parents in Muslim and Dalit tolas to send their children to school provide the empirical grounding for his literary critiques. When Kamat writes, he does so from the perspective of one who has witnessed the dehumanizing effects of caste socialization firsthand. His critique

is therefore an act of "Parallel History" in itself—a documentation of the struggles that the official record historically ignores.

**Navya Nyaya Epistemology as a Precision Instrument of Critique**

A unique characteristic of the Videha movement, and by extension Kamat's critical environment, is the application of Navya Nyaya (New Logic) to literary and social analysis. Founded by Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya in Mithila during the 14th century, Navya Nyaya is a system of extraordinary technical rigor that focuses on the precision of language and the correspondence between cognition and reality.

**The Technique of Avacchedakatva (Delimitation)**

Central to Gaṅgeśa's *Tattvacintāmaṇi* is the concept of *avacchedakatva*, or the state of being a delimitor. An *avacchedaka* is a property that specifies or limits a relationship, ensuring that a definition is neither too broad (*ativyāpti*) nor too narrow (*avyāpti*). In the context of Lal Dev Kamat's critique, this technique is used to redefine "Maithil identity."

Traditional Maithili identity was delimited by caste and Sanskrit proficiency. The Videha movement uses the logic of *avacchedaka* to shift this delimitor. By defining the "Maithil" through the lens of the "Parallel History," the movement excludes the "Brahminical patriarchy" as the sole delimiting property of the language's history. When Kamat reviews works like Raj Kishore Mishra's *Shri Mithila*, he applies a form of delimitation that recognizes the "beauty of expression" (*bhasha-saundarya*) but limits its historical relevance if it fails to account for the subaltern experience.

**Sabdabodha and the Ontology of the Digital**

Kamat's essay, "The Internet Man of Maithili: Gajendra Thakur," can be analyzed through the Navya Nyaya theory of *śābdabodha* (verbal cognition). Gaṅgeśa argues that the meaning of a root word refers to an actual physical action in the world (*phalānukūlavyāpāra*) rather than a mere mental concept. For Kamat, the "Internet" is not a conceptual tool; it is the physical operation (*vyāpāra*) that produces the result (*phala*) of language survival.

By labeling Thakur the "Internet Man," Kamat identifies the specific causal agency that allows Maithili to bypass institutional gates. In Navya Nyaya terms, the internet acts as the *nimitta-kāraṇa* (instrumental cause) for the revitalization of the language. This logic provides a rigorous philosophical defense for why digital platforms are superior to traditional institutions in the

current age: they enable a more direct correspondence between the "content of cognition" (the lived experience of all Maithils) and the "world as it is".

| Navya Nyaya Term | Logic Definition | Applied Literary Critique |
|---|---|---|
| **Avacchedaka** | Delimitor of a class or property. | Used to define "subaltern" as the essential property of the Parallel History. |
| **Pratiyogitā** | Counterpositiveness (defining absence). | Analyzing the *absence* of Dalit voices in official Maithili literature. |
| **Vyāpāra** | Operation conducive to a result. | The act of digital archiving as the operation for language preservation. |
| **Saṅgati** | Structural relevance or | The link between |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | coherence. | social activism in tolas and literary production. |
| **Śābdabodha** | The process of understanding verbal meaning. | How digital texts communicate the reality of caste struggle. |

**Indian and Western Criticism: Synthesizing Rasa and Marxist Praxis**

Lal Dev Kamat's work demonstrates a sophisticated blending of classical Indian aesthetics and Western social theory. While he utilizes terms like *madhurya rasa* (sweetness) and *geyta* (musicality) when reviewing poetry, he simultaneously engages in a Marxist deconstruction of social structures.

**Re-envisioning Rasa in the Subaltern Context**

In his critique of *Shri Mithila*, Kamat highlights the "beauty of language and expression". In classical Indian theory, *Rasa* is the aesthetic flavor that evokes a particular emotional state in the reader. However, in the Videha Parallel History, *Rasa* is often subverted. Instead of the traditional *Shringara* (erotic) or *Bhakti* (devotional) Rasas that dominated elite Maithili literature, Kamat and his contemporaries focus on the "Rasa of Life-Witnessing."

This new aesthetic is rooted in the "throbbing human heart" of the marginalized. When Kamat describes his work in Dalit colonies, he is evoking a sense of *Karuna* (compassion) and *Veera* (heroism/perseverance) that is grounded in material struggle rather than mythological tropes. This shift mirrors Western movements toward social realism, where the "truth" of the text is found in its accurate portrayal of the human condition.

**Marxist Critique and the Panji System**

The Videha movement's denunciation of the Panji system—the elaborate genealogical records of elite Maithil Brahmins—is a classic Marxist critique of ideological superstructures. The Parallel History movement views the Panji records not as sacred texts but as tools used by the elite to maintain social and

economic control. Kamat’s alignment with this view is significant; it positions him as a critic who looks beyond the "text" of a genealogy to the "power dynamics" it reinforces.

Research within the Videha framework suggests that elite sub-castes like the Srotriyas were an artificial creation of the British Permanent Settlement era, designed to consolidate power. Kamat’s work as an educator in "toals" (segregated colonies) is the practical application of this critique. He identifies the school as the site where the "Brahminical patriarchy" of the Panji system is challenged through the democratization of knowledge.

**Lal Dev Kamat as a Social Critic and Life-Witness**

Lal Dev Kamat’s bibliography, though dispersed across digital archives and audiobooks, reveals a consistent focus on the intersection of education, technology, and social justice. His essay on Gajendra Thakur, featured in the audiobook "A Bridge Built for the Sake of Love," is a foundational text for understanding the digital evolution of Mithila.

**The "Internet Man" and Digital Sovereignty**

In "The Internet Man of Maithili," Kamat argues that Gajendra Thakur’s primary achievement is the creation of a "Digital Library" that functions as a "Boon for People Fond of Reading and Studying". This is not merely technological praise; it is a critique of the "knowledge monopoly" held by physical institutions. By providing free access to Maithili books, fonts (Tirhuta, Kaithi, Newari), and standard spelling guides, the Videha movement establishes "digital sovereignty" for the Maithili language.

Kamat recognizes that the internet allows Maithili to exist independently of state borders or institutional approval. This is particularly important for a language like Maithili, which is spoken across India and Nepal and has a vast diaspora. The digital archive, therefore, is the ultimate *avacchedaka* (delimitor) of the language's future—it ensures that Maithili is defined by its global community of speakers rather than a local elite.

**Character Complexity and Caste Socialization**

Kamat’s sensibilities as a social critic are echoed in the literary analyses provided by the Videha movement. For instance, the analysis of the child-character "Shriya" in *Black Ink* highlights a "subtle portrayal of caste socialization". Shriya is simultaneously innocent and the "unconscious carrier of her parents' caste-prejudice." This complexity is what Kamat looks for in

modern literature—a rejection of two-dimensional characters in favor of "life-witnessing" that accounts for the messy realities of social identity.

Similarly, the movement's focus on the "Third Gender" and the struggles of married women (the "identity crisis" Kamat notes in his childhood observations) reflects a commitment to intersectionality that is rare in traditional Maithili circles. Kamat's observation that women are often known only by their relation to their children (*gudia ki amma*) rather than their own names is a poignant critique of the "Brahminical patriarchy" that the Parallel History Framework seeks to dismantle.

**The Evolution of the Maithili Novel: A Parallel Perspective**

The Videha movement has documented a clear shift in the themes of Maithili novels over the last century. Kamat operates in an environment where the novel has transformed from a tool of "social reconstruction" to a "thriller film" like depiction of the politics-crime nexus.

| Novel | Theme | Framework Context |
|---|---|---|
| *Kanyadan* (1933) | Early social reform (child marriage) | Official Tradition's reformist phase. |
| *Bhamati* (2010) | Historical/ Classical | Award-winning, yet within the institutional fold. |
| *Pangu* (2021) | Contemporary struggle | Focus on disability and social marginalization. |
| *Subhim* | Third Gender | First Maithili |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| *ani Jingi* | | work on gender identity. |
| *Herayal Jingi* | Post-independence critique | Critiques the "faulty development model" of Mithila. |

Kamat's own work, such as his review of *Shri Mithila*, must be seen against this backdrop. While *Shri Mithila* is a "brief historical kavya," Kamat emphasizes its "simplicity and ease of expression," aligning it with the modern trend of making literature accessible to the "common people" who now use laptops and mobiles. This "mechanical age" turning into an "electronic and internet age" is the definitive shift that Kamat chronicles in his critique of the "Internet Man".

**Logic, Language, and Artificial Intelligence: The Future of Mithila**

A profound insight generated by the Videha movement is the compatibility of Navya Nyaya with modern computing. The hierarchical use of limitors (*avacchedakas*) to define relations is described as a "map for how language tracks correspondence with the real world," a concept directly applicable to Artificial Intelligence and Natural Language Processing (NLP).

Kamat's focus on digital standardization—dictionaries and fonts—is the necessary groundwork for this technological future. By applying the "precision instruments" of Gaṅgeśa to the digital archive, the Videha movement ensures that Maithili is not just preserved as a "museum piece" but is equipped to function in a world of AI and global connectivity. In this sense, Kamat is a "futurist" critic; he uses the logic of the 14th century to secure the survival of his language in the 22nd century.

**Existentialism and the Paradox of Dehumanization**

The Videha movement also explores existentialist themes, particularly the "cosmic indifference" of the world to human suffering. The novel *The Crow* is cited for its "inverted introduction," where a human is described as an animal and an animal (Shadool) as a gentle human creature. This paradox reflects the dehumanization inherent in the caste system—a theme central to Kamat's pedagogical work. By advocating for the education of Dalit and Muslim

children, Kamat is effectively working to "humanize" those whom the traditional social order has sought to treat as "animals".

**Synthesizing the Critique: The Legacy of Lal Dev Kamat**

Lal Dev Kamat’s work represents a vital synthesis of the "Jan Kavi" (people’s poet) tradition and the rigorous intellectual heritage of Mithila. His critique is grounded in three essential pillars:

1. **Navya Nyaya Precision:** Using the techniques of Gaṅgeśa to define the limits of identity and the causal mechanisms of language revitalization.
2. **Subaltern Representation:** Aligning with the Videha Parallel History Framework to give voice to the "missing portions" of society (Dalits, women, Muslims) and rejecting the "Brahminical patriarchy" of the Panji system.
3. **Digital Democratization:** Recognizing the internet as the ultimate tool for literary survival and the dismantling of institutional gatekeepers.

Kamat’s review of *Shri Mithila* and his essay on the "Internet Man" are not disconnected works; they are part of a "Synthetic Historiography" that seeks to reintegrate all facets of Maithili life—from the Nepal legacies to the Dalit folk heroes—into a unified, democratic account. His life and work serve as a "saṅgati" (relevance relation) between the ancient logic of Mithila and the urgent demands of 21st-century social justice.

the critique of Lal Dev Kamat is a critique of the transformative power of the Parallel Tradition. Through the lens of Navya Nyaya, Kamat identifies the *avacchedaka* of the modern Maithili experience as one of digital liberation and subaltern resistance. His work ensures that the "throbbing human heart" of Mithila continues to beat, not in the sanitized halls of state academies, but in the vibrant, open, and democratic spaces of the digital world. He remains a pivotal figure in the Videha movement, a bridge between the classical past and the subaltern future, and a testament to the enduring power of logic in the service of justice.

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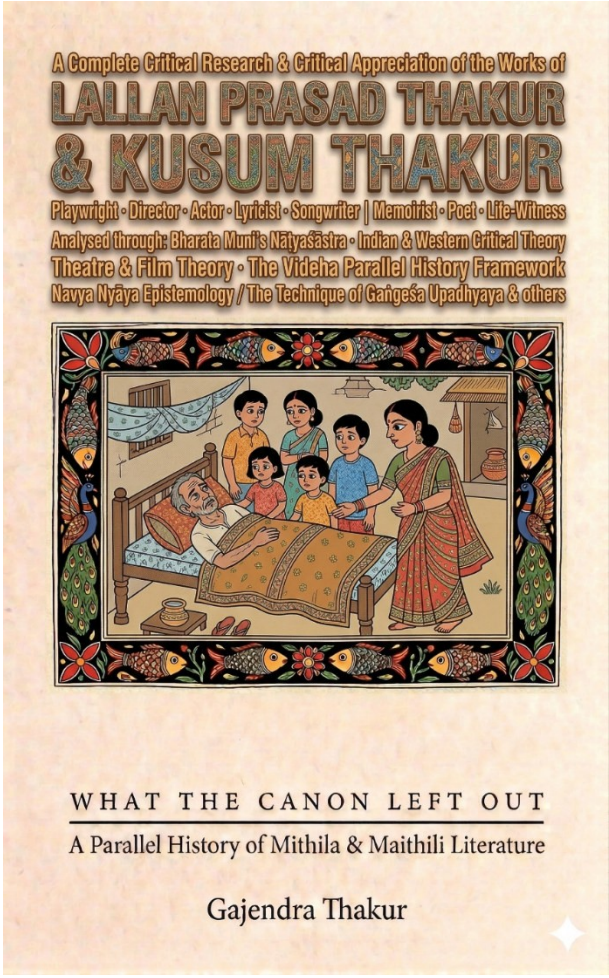
**LESSON 042 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**




# A COMPLETE CRITICAL RESEARCH & CRITICAL APPRECIATION

of the Works of

**LALLAN PRASAD THAKUR**

**& KUSUM THAKUR**

*Playwright · Director · Actor · Lyricist · Songwriter | Memoirist · Poet · Life-Witness*

Analysed through: Bharata Muni's Nāṭyaśāstra · Indian & Western Critical Theory

Theatre & Film Theory · The Videha Parallel History Framework

Navya Nyāya Epistemology / The Technique of Gaṅgeśa Upadhyaya & others

# PART I: INTRODUCTION AND BIOGRAPHICAL OVERVIEW

## 1.1 The Literary Couple of Mithila: An Overview

Lallan Prasad Thakur (5 January 1953 – 7 September 1995) was a playwright, director, actor, lyricist, songwriter, and cultural activist in the Maithili and Hindi languages of Mithila. Born in village Samaul, Madhubani district, Mithila (Bihar), he completed his schooling at Watson Higher Secondary School, Madhubani (1967) and earned his civil engineering degree from M.I.T. Muzaffarpur (1973). He worked as an engineer in TISCO (Tata Iron and Steel Company), Jamshedpur, in the CE&DD division. In his brief creative life of barely twelve years on the proscenium stage — beginning with the premiere of Badka Saheb at Rabindra Bhavan, Jamshedpur, on 20 November 1983 — he produced a body of theatrical work that critics have placed in the front rank of Maithili drama.

Kusum Thakur, his wife (married 13 July 1972), is a memoirist, poet, and prose writer. Her memoir Pratyavartan (Return / Restoration), preserved in Videha Sadeha 34, is one of the most candid and luminous autobiographical texts in modern Maithili literature. Her poems, including Chul Buli Kanya Bani Gelahuṃ (I Became a Mischievous Girl Again) and Abhilasha (Longing), show a quiet but deeply felt lyric intelligence. The two writers must be understood both independently and in their creative partnership: Kusum Thakur was, by her own account, Lallan Prasad Thakur's first and most demanding critic, his most thorough admirer, and an indispensable collaborator in the development of every play.

## 1.2 Life and Career of Lallan Prasad Thakur

Family: Son of Hiranand Thakur and Subhadra Devi. Second child among two sisters and six brothers. Elder brother Yashoanand Thakur was his first theatrical inspiration; Buchi Babu, his schoolmaster, was his first theatre guru.

He is survived by Kusum Thakur (© 9431117484) and sons Kumar Bhaskar Thakur and Kumar Mayur Thakur.

Institutional affiliations: Founder of the organisation Mithilakshar (1983). Associated with Mailorang, which published his Rachanavali in 2022 (ISBN 978-93-82828-37-2, price Rs. 595, edited by Dr. Prakash Jha; cover art by Manisha Jha; cover design by Rajeev Sharma; typesetting by Sanjeev Kumar 'Bittu' and Jyuli Srivastava).

Theatrical premieres: Badka Saheb — Rabindra Bhavan, Jamshedpur, 20 November 1983. Mistaar Nilo Kaka — Bhartiya Nrityakala Mandir, Patna, 17 November 1984 and 13 June 1985 (subsequent stagings). Loangia Miarchai — multiple productions from mid-1980s. Baklel and Aadi Va Ant received notable critical attention. All Maithili plays directed by Lallan Prasad Thakur himself; he also acted the title role of Nilo Kaka.

The pivotal institutional context of Lallan Prasad Thakur's dramatic career was Mailorang and the Mithila Rang Mahotsav (Mithila Theatre Festival). The first Mithila Rang Mahotsav was organised by Mailorang in Jamshedpur in 2006, with an international seminar; this seminar first noted the absence of systematic documentation of Maithili theatre and laid the groundwork for what would become the Rachanavali. A second catalysing moment was the encounter with actress Manisha Jha (who joined Mailorang's repertory in 2016–17), whose chance remark — that Lallan Thakur was her maternal uncle — opened the path to Kusum Thakur and eventually to the publication of the collected works.

## 1.3 Critical Reception in Brief — Lallan Prasad Thakur

The critical consensus recorded in the Rachanavali's memorial section (Smaran) draws on tributes from the journal Bhangima (December 1995, Issue 23) and from leading Maithili literary figures. The most significant testimonials are:

> *"Lallan Prasad Thakur depicted social problems and understood the limits of the proscenium stage, keeping the tastes of the people in mind. His plays became popular and began to be staged village by village. [He] brought a new turn to the mainstream of Maithili drama." — Anand Mishra*
>
> *"He was an extremely talented writer, director, and serious actor. His Baklel, in particular, makes one think of questions that have haunted the educated classes of Mithila for generations." — Pandit Govind Jha*
>
> *"In only ten years of play-writing Lallan Prasad Thakur achieved a prestige and success that it would be impossible for many to achieve. He was a creative*

*person. He wanted to do everything for the progress of Maithili." — Chhatranand Singh Jha*

*"In Lallan Prasad Thakur's plays, from a small to a large city, from a mohalla to a complete society, his plays can be staged very easily." — Vibhuti Anand*

*"Lallan Prasad Thakur's plays leave no doubt that he was fully sensitive to the problems of the life of his era, that he was concerned about their consequences, that he had the desire to see society free of pollution." — Ramanand Jha 'Raman'*

*"Ganga Esh Gupta felt that he [Lallan Prasad Thakur] had written at least five or five notable plays — and these would give a long and glorious life to Maithili theatre." — Gangesh Gunjan*

# PART II: ANNOTATED BIBLIOGRAPHY OF WORKS

## 2.1 Maithili Plays (Natak) — Lallan Prasad Thakur

### *2.1.1 Badka Saheb (Big Sahib / The Great Sahib)*

First staged: Rabindra Bhavan, Jamshedpur, 20 November 1983. Direction: Lallan Prasad Thakur. Principal cast: Chheddi Jha (Lallan Prasad Thakur), Chudamani Jha; Bhola (Laxmikant Jha); Meena (Smt. Meena Thakur); Mikki (Kumari Nalini Jha); Bikki (Kumar Mayur); B.C. Jha (Purnanand Jha); Rani (Kumari Bandana Mishra); Barma Ji (Nilambar Chaudhary). Music: Raja. Art: K.P. Rao.

The play is a satirical comedy of manners centred on Balchandra Jha — a self-important IAS officer who has lost touch with his village origins. The opening scene, in which Chheddi Jha (an elderly villager) and Chudamani (a village student) arrive at Balchandra's city bungalow and are confronted by a nameplate reading 'B.C. Jha' and 'Balchandra Jha' — characters unable to parse the English initials — is a masterpiece of comic misrecognition. The play is organised around the contrast between the village world (represented by Chheddi and Chudamani's earthy Maithili wit, close to the Gonu Jha folk tradition) and the city world of officials, lawyers, and social climbers.

The Maithili of the dialogue is extremely close to the spoken register of rural Madhubani district, with idiomatic expressions (gharbalika kirpa se — 'by your wife's grace', a phrase that recurs as a leitmotif of satirical deflation) that would resonate with every village audience. The stage directions are unusually detailed, specifying the use of slide projections for character introductions and shadow-play sequences for the opening — a formally sophisticated choice for Maithili theatre of 1983.

### *2.1.2 Mistaar Nilo Kaka (Mr. Nilo Uncle)*

First staged: Bhartiya Nrityakala Mandir, Patna, 17 November 1984 (and 13 June 1985). Direction and title role: Lallan Prasad Thakur. Cast included Vandana Mishra / Kusum Thakur as Lilavati; Purnanand Jha / Balmukund Chaudhary as the Minister and other roles.

The play depicts Nilo Kaka — a man of enormous local influence, without land or legal title, who operates through sheer force of personality, wit, and a lifetime of accumulated social capital. The play is structured around ten scenes

(dashyam), ranging from Nilo's domestic quarters (where he applies face cream and listens to the song 'Bol Radha Bol' on a tape recorder while his servant Chalitra polishes his shoes) to a tea-shop, a Minister's residence in Patna, and finally to a hunger strike. The political satire is sharp: Nilo Kaka, having built his reputation as a local champion, is pressured by young men (Ramesh, Gulab) to go on hunger strike in protest at the Chief Minister's indifference to their region's underdevelopment — a road not built, a school in disrepair, no government ration shop. The final scene, in which the Chief Minister arrives to meet Nilo on his deathbed (after fifteen days of fasting), is a bitter comedy: the government concedes all demands, but Nilo has already expired.

The play is notable for its extended monologues (Nilo's tirades against lawyers, politicians, and the municipal system), its use of Maithili proverbs and folk sayings, and its ironic treatment of the politician-voter relationship. The Maithili is at its most colloquial here — dense with vernacular humour — and the performance records (Kusum Thakur's memoir, reviews in Bhangima) indicate that Lallan's own performance as Nilo was considered his finest theatrical achievement.

### *2.1.3 Loangia Miarchai (The Chilli of Loangia)*

A more complex play than the preceding two, Loangia Miarchai is set in a village and introduces the character of Ghutar (a fifty-year-old villager), a Maithili-medium professor Chandrakant, his associate Phukna, and the rural schoolmaster. The title derives from the allegorical figure of the chilli — sharp, locally grown, pungent — which serves as a metaphor for the village intellectual tradition and its gradual erosion by urban modernity.

The play addresses the theme of Maithili-medium education and the pressures on village teachers. The dialogue includes a biting exchange in which the professor defends traditional Mithila marriage customs (the custom of holding the bride's nose at the wedding ceremony) as epistemologically meaningful — 'What is blocked [by the nose-holding] is the breath, [and] one can die [if it is truly blocked]!' — and argues that this custom reflects a system of social knowledge that urban reformers cannot understand. The play's social critique is thus double-edged: it satirises backwardness but also the facile modernism of educated Maithilis who have lost their roots.

### *2.1.4 Baklel*

Baklel is regarded by several critics — including Govind Jha and the editors of Bhangima — as Lallan Prasad Thakur's most intellectually challenging play.

Set in the industrial city of Jamshedpur (Lohanagaria in the play), it depicts a young engineer from Mithila who has absorbed urban culture but is haunted by his village origins. The title Baklel is a Maithili coinage that suggests both 'confused' and 'divided' — a man between two worlds. The play premiered at the Fifth International Maithili Theatre Festival in Delhi (Pyarelal Bhavan, Akhil Bhartiya Mithila Sangh organising). It won the festival's best play award.

The playwright Govind Jha (a leading Maithili critic) writes: 'Those who know the original [Nilo Kaka play] find Baklel's questions still entering their heads in those days [after seeing the play] — and it is exactly on that [quality] that I feel Lallan Prasad Thakur's hand still moves on my back, whose touch I cannot forget even now.' Vibhuti Anand writes: 'Through simple, non-pretentious, sensitive village characters as his medium, he [Lallan Prasad Thakur] struck blows at insensitivity, de-culturalisation, corrupt political-social systems, class distinctions, and the education system.'

### *2.1.5 Aadi Va Ant (Beginning and End)*

The fifth major play, Aadi Va Ant, addresses existential themes more directly than the earlier social comedies. The title signals a philosophical ambition — the play moves from the comedy of social manners toward a meditation on mortality and purpose. The stage directions indicate a sophisticated use of lighting to divide the stage into past and present zones. The play includes songs (notably Sankalpa Liya — Resolution Taken) that function as thematic anchors.

## 2.2 Maithili One-Act Plays (Ekanki)

- Chanda — a one-act play; notable for its tight construction and single-setting domestic drama.
- Green Room — set backstage in a theatre; a meta-theatrical piece that brings the world of Maithili theatre actors into dramatic focus.
- Suitcase — a comic one-act structured around a misplaced suitcase and its revelations about character.
- Maithili Film — a satirical one-act about the attempted production of a Maithili language film; one of the earliest theatrical treatments of Maithili cinema as a subject.

## 2.3 Maithili Geet-Natika (Musical Drama / Operettas)

- Sabhagachhi — a musical play built around a community assembly (sabha).
- Sarhenaama — a farewell / eulogy piece for theatrical performance.

- Ghatkaithi — a dramatic piece dealing with threshold rituals in the Maithili tradition.

## 2.4 Songs and Lyrics (Maithili)

Lallan Prasad Thakur composed original lyrics for all his plays and several stand-alone songs. The Rachanavali includes: Sankalp Liya (Resolve Taken — opening song); Tore Lel Analahun Hathi Ghoda (I Brought for You Elephants and Horses — lullaby song); Lalmunia (folk song); Chuk Chuk Chuk Chuk Chuk Chuk (train song for children); Bita Ya Din Sab Mon Padaya; He Re Chanda; Dil Dhadkal Aankhi Pharkal; Ahan Hamar Ke Chhi; Sab El Ya Phaguame Sajna; Madhur Madhur Bajay Bansuriya Re; Haiya Re — Haiya Re (boatman song); Gor Gor Gor Sab Chhai Gor; Mon Ne Lag Ya Ahan Bina; all in the lyrical Maithili register.

## 2.5 Hindi Plays — Lallan Prasad Thakur

### *2.5.1 Sooni Sadak (The Empty Street)*

A full-length Hindi play set in an urban context. The play explores the intersection of personal despair and political betrayal in contemporary India. The dialogue is notably crisper than the Maithili plays — a register shift that allows Lallan Prasad Thakur to address a pan-Indian audience while maintaining his satirical edge.

### *2.5.2 Dam Dam Diga Diga*

A Hindi play whose title mimics the sound of a drum. The play has a festive, carnivalesque energy (Bakhtinian in retrospect) — a drum-beat that cuts through pretension — while addressing serious themes of political corruption and communal identity.

## 2.6 Hindi One-Act Plays

- Sahayog (Cooperation) — explores collective action in an urban slum setting.
- Suhaagarat (Wedding Night) — a bittersweet one-act about newly-wed expectations and social reality.

In addition, the Rachanavali includes a section Sasmaran: Ardhanginni — a tribute poem and letter to Kusum Thakur by Lallan Prasad Thakur, reprinted in the memorial section together with Kusum Thakur's Shraddhanajali Geet and the poem Chahat Tumhari Phir Se.

## 2.7 Works of Kusum Thakur

### *2.7.1 Pratyavartan (Return / Restoration)*

Published in Videha Sadeha 34, pp. 459–572. ISSN 2229-547X, 2022. A memoir of extraordinary intimacy and social depth. The text is structured in numbered sections (1–onwards), moving from Kusum Thakur's childhood marriage at age fifteen, to her life as an engineering student's wife, to the creative collaboration with Lallan Prasad Thakur, and finally to her confrontation with his illness and death and her own process of return to creative life.

The memoir is framed by a statement of purpose in the opening section: 'In 1996, I was asked to write something for a magazine. I could only write: I don't know what to write — my pen itself has been lost. But today it seems that I have a duty to perform.' The word Pratyavartan itself — meaning both 'return' and 'restitution/restoration' — encodes the dual nature of the text: a personal return to voice after grief, and a literary restoration of Lallan Prasad Thakur's memory.

The social dimension of the memoir is equally significant. Kusum Thakur's account of her child marriage (she was at a relative's wedding when she discovered she was the bride), her negotiation between village and city life, her relationship with her mother-in-law (who held a water-throwing ritual before the wedding procession departed, as a fertility blessing), and her gradual entry into the world of Maithili theatre — all constitute a social history of educated middle-class Mithila in the 1970s and 1980s that no purely fictional account could achieve.

### *2.7.2 Chul Buli Kanya Bani Gelahuṃ (I Became a Mischievous Girl Again)*

A lyric poem published in Videha Sadeha 34, p. 1090. The poem enacts a recovery of playful selfhood after years of grief and duty. The speaker, who has 'forgotten her desires and dreams for many years', suddenly finds herself transformed by an unnamed force — 'faith in someone' — into the mischievous, spirited girl she was before marriage. The poem's central image ('I became the mischievous girl again') resonates with the Pratyavartan memoir's title: both text and poem enact a return.

### *2.7.3 Abhilasha (Longing)*

A poem in Videha Sadeha 34, p. 1090–1091. The poem is a meditation on the unfulfilled desire to have a daughter. The speaker imagines all the care she

would give — the daughter as 'the ornament of the natal home', the preparation of tilak at her wedding — and then confronts the poem's turn: 'One only deficiency remained — / the tilak was not applied.' The poem is formally tight, emotionally resonant, and politically aware (it acknowledges the cultural preference for sons without polemicising it).

# PART III: THEORETICAL FRAMEWORKS — THEATRE, FILM & DRAMA

## 3.1 Bharata Muni's Nāṭyaśāstra: The Foundational Framework

### *3.1.1 The Origin and Purpose of Drama*

The Nāṭyaśāstra (composed between c. 200 BCE and 200 CE, attributed to Bharata Muni) is the oldest and most comprehensive treatise on theatre in any language. Its opening chapter (Nāṭyotpatti) establishes the fifth Veda — the Veda of drama — as a democratic institution: drawn from the four existing Vedas (text from the Rigveda, song from the Samaveda, gesture from the Yajurveda, rasa/emotion from the Atharvaveda), the Nāṭya Veda is explicitly for all people, including those denied access to the other Vedas. This democratic mandate is directly relevant to Lallan Prasad Thakur's theatrical project, which brought Maithili drama to audiences in Jamshedpur's working-class localities and to villages across Madhubani district.

### *3.1.2 Rasa Theory and Lallan Prasad Thakur's Plays*

Bharata Muni's rasa theory identifies eight primary aesthetic emotions: shringara (erotic/romantic), hasya (comic), karuna (pathetic/compassionate), raudra (furious), vira (heroic), bhayanaka (fearful), bibhatsa (disgusting), and adbhuta (wondrous). Abhinavagupta (Abhinavabharati, c. 1000 CE) added shanta (serenity/tranquillity) as a ninth.

In Lallan Prasad Thakur's plays, the dominant rasas are: hasya in Badka Saheb and Mistaar Nilo Kaka; karuna in the final scenes of Nilo Kaka (the hunger strike death) and in Baklel's exploration of existential dislocation; vira in the politically charged sequences of Nilo Kaka's hunger strike. The combination of hasya and karuna — comic satire giving way to pathos — is characteristic of his most successful plays and corresponds to what Bharata calls the composite rasa or misra rasa.

Bharata's concept of the neta (the hero) is also relevant: in Nilo Kaka, the titular character is explicitly a dhīroddhata (bold, proud) neta who refuses to be diminished by official power — a heroic type rare in Maithili drama of the period. The play's final death-scene carries the weight of both tragedy and civic eulogy, evoking the rasas of vira and karuna simultaneously.

### *3.1.3 Abhinaya: The Four Modes of Theatrical Representation*

Bharata distinguishes four modes of theatrical representation: angika (bodily gesture), vachika (verbal), sattvika (psychological/emotional authenticity), and aharya (costume/décor). Lallan Prasad Thakur's unusually detailed stage directions (extending to notes on props, lighting configurations, and the division of the stage into zones) demonstrate an acute awareness of all four modes. His specification of shadow-play effects and slide projections (in Badka Saheb) extends the aharya category into the modern theatre's use of projected imagery — anticipating the multimedia drama of the 1990s.

His own performance as Nilo Kaka is consistently described by eyewitnesses as a masterpiece of sattvika acting — the representation of inner psychological states through minimal external means. Vijay Chandra Jha's tribute notes: 'He was cheerful, friendly, divine, and more of a writer than an actor — an extraordinary man.' Kumar Shailendra's account is more analytical: 'Lallan Prasad Thakur played old characters — although he himself had not reached that stage — and with great subtlety presented these characters on stage, catching the role with precision, which greatly pleased the theatre-loving audience.'

## 3.2 Western Theatre Theory

### *3.2.1 Bertolt Brecht: Epic Theatre and the Verfremdungseffekt*

Brecht's Verfremdungseffekt (defamiliarisation or alienation effect) is the theatrical technique of interrupting the audience's emotional immersion in order to provoke critical thought. In Brecht's epic theatre, song, projected text, direct address to the audience, and visible theatrical machinery all serve to remind the spectator that they are watching a representation, not reality, and to maintain the analytical distance necessary for political engagement.

Lallan Prasad Thakur's theatrical practice shows clear affinities with Brechtian principles, even if without direct documentary influence. The use of slide projections for character introductions (Badka Saheb), the meta-theatrical one-act Green Room (set backstage, making the apparatus of theatre itself the subject), and the play Maithili Film (which theatrically represents the making of a film, collapsing the frame between medium and content) all deploy Brechtian devices. More significantly, the songs in Lallan Prasad Thakur's plays — particularly the satirical songs in Nilo Kaka — function exactly as Brecht's Lieder do: they interrupt the action and offer a commentary that steps outside the play's psychological world.

### *3.2.2 Konstantin Stanislavski: The System and Psychological Realism*

Stanislavski's System — built on the actor's emotional memory, the given circumstances of the character, and the through-action (superbjective) of a role — provides the theoretical framework for understanding Lallan Prasad Thakur's acting as Nilo Kaka. Multiple eyewitnesses describe his performance as psychologically utterly convincing — the audience laughing at Nilo's bravado while feeling the pathos of his ultimate sacrifice. This combination of comedy and pathos, performed without breaking the internal logic of the character, is precisely what Stanislavski's System aimed for: a performance that the actor experiences genuinely rather than merely demonstrates.

### *3.2.3 Peter Brook: The Empty Space*

Peter Brook's concept of the Empty Space (1968) — the idea that any space marked as theatrical becomes a stage — is relevant to Lallan Prasad Thakur's practice of staging plays in diverse conditions: from Rabindra Bhavan (a proscenium theatre) to village performance spaces, from Jamshedpur to Patna to Delhi. His detailed stage directions always include notes on how to adapt the staging for minimal-resource conditions — a practical acknowledgment that Maithili theatre must work in the Empty Space as well as the full theatre building.

### *3.2.4 Augusto Boal: Theatre of the Oppressed*

Augusto Boal's Theatre of the Oppressed (1979) developed from his experience with oppressed Brazilian communities: it uses theatrical techniques (forum theatre, invisible theatre, image theatre) to give communities the tools to analyse and transform their social conditions. The resonance with Lallan Prasad Thakur's theatrical project is structural rather than direct. His audience — Jamshedpur's Maithili-speaking working class and the rural population of Madhubani district — were precisely the communities that mainstream Hindi and English theatre ignored. His plays staged their concerns (corruption, unemployment, educational deprivation, the rural-urban divide) in their own language and cultural idiom.

## 3.3 Film Theory and the One-Act Maithili Film

### *3.3.1 Maithili Cinema and Lallan Prasad Thakur's One-Act*

The one-act play Maithili Film is historically significant as one of the earliest theatrical treatments of the aspiration for Maithili cinema. At the time of Lallan

Prasad Thakur's death in 1995, Maithili cinema was in its earliest phases of development (the first widely distributed Maithili films appeared in the 1980s). The play satirises the gap between the cultural aspiration (making a Maithili film) and the material conditions (lack of infrastructure, funds, trained personnel). The one-act also looks forward to the filmmaker Prakash Jha's actual engagement with Maithili/Bihar cinema — since Prakash Jha (who edited the Rachanavali and appears in the memorial tributes as a 'film producer and director') was among the cultural circle around Lallan Prasad Thakur.

### *3.3.2 Siegfried Kracauer and the Reality Effect*

Kracauer's Theory of Film (1960) argues that cinema is the only medium that can redeem physical reality — that it captures the texture of everyday life in ways that other art forms cannot. Lallan Prasad Thakur's theatrical work anticipates this aesthetic: his plays are dense with the specific material texture of Maithili everyday life (the tea-shop bench reserved for Nilo Kaka, the face cream and audio cassette in Nilo's bedroom, the nameplate reading 'B.C. Jha', the chilli of Loangia village). This documentary attention to material reality — what Kracauer calls the 'found story' as opposed to the 'staged story' — gives his plays a social-realist dimension that film theory helps illuminate.

# PART IV: INDIAN AND WESTERN CRITICAL THEORY

## 4.1 Indian Critical Theory

### *4.1.1 Rasa and Dhvani Applied to Lallan Prasad Thakur*

Anandavardhana's dhvani (resonance/suggestion) theory holds that the highest literary expression operates through implied meaning. In Nilo Kaka's hunger strike sequence, the implied meaning goes far beyond the literal narrative: the dhvani of political betrayal resonates through the comedy of Nilo's deceptions and self-deceptions, so that when he dies just as the government concedes, the audience experiences the implied tragedy without it being stated. This dhvani-rich structure is what distinguishes the play from straightforward political satire.

Kuntaka's vakrokti (oblique expression) theory argues that literary art achieves its effects through deviation from the ordinary. The structural obliqueness of Nilo Kaka — presenting a corruption-busting political hero whose own methods include bribery, cunning, and personal charm — is a form of vakrokti: the 'hero' is heroic only obliquely, through his wit rather than his virtue.

### *4.1.2 Abhinavagupta's Sadharanikarana and the Audience*

Abhinavagupta's concept of sadharanikarana (universalisation) holds that aesthetic experience transcends the particular viewer's personal emotions and creates a shared, universalised aesthetic state in the community of spectators (sahridaya). Lallan Prasad Thakur's plays, rooted in the particular culture of Mithila, achieve sadharanikarana through the universality of their themes: the corruption of power, the gap between aspiration and reality, the pain of cultural displacement. That his plays were performed from Jamshedpur to Patna to Delhi — across radically different Maithili-speaking audiences — indicates that the sadharanikarana mechanism was fully operative.

## 4.2 Western Critical Theory

### *4.2.1 Mikhail Bakhtin: Carnivalesque, Heteroglossia, Dialogism*

Bakhtin's concept of the carnivalesque — the festive inversion of social hierarchies, the laughter that exposes the pretensions of power — is directly operative in Lallan Prasad Thakur's dramatic universe. Nilo Kaka, like the

original Gonu Jha trickster tradition that pervades Mithila's oral culture, is a carnivalesque figure: he outsmarts collectors, ministers, and lawyers not by occupying their positions but by exposing the absurdity of those positions through wit. The tea-shop as his court (in Nilo Kaka, the reserved bench is his throne), the village as his domain against the city — these are carnivalesque inversions of the official power structure.

Bakhtin's heteroglossia — the co-presence of multiple social registers, dialects, and voices in a text — is also visible in Lallan Prasad Thakur's dialogue. The Maithili of the village characters (dense with idiom, proverb, and regional expression) coexists with the Maithili of the educated urban characters (partly Sanskritised, partly Hindi-inflected), and with the English of official notices and nameplates (B.C. Jha). This three-level linguistic structure is a precise representation of Mithila's social stratification.

### *4.2.2 Antonio Gramsci: Hegemony and the Organic Intellectual*

Gramsci's concept of the organic intellectual — an intellectual who arises from and remains connected to a specific class or community, representing its interests and articulating its culture — describes Lallan Prasad Thakur precisely. As an engineer at TISCO (a working-class industrial context) who created plays about rural Mithila for the Jamshedpur Maithili community, he occupied the exact position Gramsci describes: not a detached intellectual but one embedded in the material conditions of the community whose culture he represented.

The hegemonic structure he challenged was twofold: the dominance of Hindi and English in public cultural life (which marginalised Maithili), and the dominance of a Brahmin-centred Maithili literary establishment (which, in the Videha parallel-history framework's terms, excluded the democratic folk tradition). Lallan Prasad Thakur's theatre was a counter-hegemonic institution precisely because it was produced outside the official cultural apparatus.

### *4.2.3 Frantz Fanon: Cultural Identity and Decolonisation*

Fanon's The Wretched of the Earth (1961) argues that cultural decolonisation — the recovery of the colonised people's own cultural forms, languages, and histories — is inseparable from political decolonisation. The Maithili theatre movement of which Lallan Prasad Thakur was part operates on this Fanonian logic: the production of theatre in Maithili, for Maithili-speaking communities, in the idiom of Maithili folk culture (Gonu Jha wit, folk song registers, village

customs), constitutes a cultural self-determination that the dominance of Hindi in Bihar's public life had suppressed.

### *4.2.4 Sandra Gilbert & Susan Gubar / Feminist Theory — Applied to Kusum Thakur*

Showalter's gynocriticism and Gilbert & Gubar's analysis of women's writing in The Madwoman in the Attic are relevant to Kusum Thakur's literary situation. Her memoir Pratyavartan begins with the confession that she had 'lost her pen' — a metaphor for the suppression of creative voice in the domestic and social roles imposed upon her. The first-person narrator of Pratyavartan is a woman who was married at fifteen without her knowledge or consent, who gradually discovered her own creative voice through partnership with an extraordinary theatrical husband, and who must then reconstruct that voice after his death. The memoir enacts what Gilbert and Gubar call the 'revision' — the rewriting of the self's story in its own terms.

# PART V: THE VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY FRAMEWORK

## 5.1 The Parallel History and Maithili Drama

Gajendra Thakur's A Parallel History of Mithila & Maithili Literature (Videha, Parts 1–46+, www.videha.co.in) documents the systematic suppression of democratic, folk, Dalit, and feminist literary traditions in Maithili by the official Sahitya Akademi apparatus. The RTI data gathered by Vinit Utpal and Ashish Anchinhar (2011–14) confirmed that over 90% of Sahitya Akademi assignments went to friends and relatives of the advisory board. Lallan Prasad Thakur, who died in 1995, and whose best plays were composed between 1983 and 1995, received no Sahitya Akademi recognition in his lifetime.

Within the Parallel History Framework's schema, Lallan Prasad Thakur occupies a position analogous to the 'living masters' identified in the framework — Rajdeo Mandal, Bechan Thakur, Jagdish Prasad Mandal — who were long ignored by official machinery. The key parallel is with Bechan Thakur: Gajendra Thakur's entry in Videha Sadeha 34 discusses Bechan Thakur's theatre as the defining parallel tradition of Maithili drama. Both Bechan Thakur and Lallan Prasad Thakur created popular-democratic theatre in the Jamshedpur / village milieu, outside the Patna/Delhi official cultural apparatus.

## 5.2 The Mailorang Cultural Institution

Mailorang (Maillorang, lit. 'Maithili Colours'), which published the Rachanavali and organised the Mithila Rang Mahotsav from 2006, is itself an example of the parallel cultural institution that the Videha movement documents as the counter-archive. The Preface to the Rachanavali explicitly describes the documentation project: 'There was no organised Maithili drama research institution — if there had been, the plays would have been documented long ago.' The Rachanavali is thus a parallel act of archival recovery, rescuing from oblivion plays that had existed only in individual performance memories and scattered photocopies.

## 5.3 Gangesh Upadhyaya and the Parallel History of Navya Nyaya

The Parallel History's central scholarly intervention regarding Gangesh Upadhyaya — the founder of Navya Nyaya logic, whose Tattvachintamani (13th century CE, Mithila) is one of the most rigorous works of epistemology in any tradition — reveals that he was born of an inter-caste union suppressed by

the Brahmin literary establishment. This biographical suppression is directly relevant to understanding the epistemic politics of Lallan Prasad Thakur's theatre: a theatre that gave voice to non-Brahmin villagers (the Ghutar of Loangia Miarchai, the Chheddi of Badka Saheb) against the pretensions of the official class.

# PART VI: NAVYA NYĀYA EPISTEMOLOGY AND THE TECHNIQUE OF GAṄGEŚA UPADHYAYA

## 6.1 Gangesh Upadhyaya and the Tattvachintamani

Gaṅgeśa Upadhyaya (c. 13th century CE, Mithila) is the founder of the Navya Nyāya (New Logic) school, the dominant tradition of philosophical analysis in Mithila for several centuries. His Tattvachintamani (Jewel of Reflection on the True Nature of Things) develops a highly precise formal language for analysing the structure of knowledge (pramana), inference (anumana), and linguistic meaning (sabda). The school's technical vocabulary — including concepts of vyapti (invariable concomitance), paksha (subject), sadhya (predicate), hetu (reason), and upAdhi (limiting condition) — constitutes a full-scale formal logic comparable in rigour to modern symbolic logic.

## 6.2 Navya Nyaya Applied to the Critical Analysis of Drama

### *6.2.1 Vyapti (Invariable Concomitance) in the Theatre of Social Reality*

In Navya Nyaya, vyapti is the invariable concomitance between two properties — the logical foundation of inference. Applied to drama criticism: the critical claim that Lallan Prasad Thakur's plays produce genuine social critique (sadhya) is based on the hetu (reason) that they dramatise specific social conditions (corruption, unemployment, linguistic marginalisation) in the idiom of those who live those conditions. The vyapti linking this representation to social critique is: wherever a dramatist represents social conditions from within the community's own cultural logic, social critique is produced that would not be produced by external representation.

### *6.2.2 Sabda Pramana (Verbal Testimony) and the Memoir Pratyavartan*

In Nyaya epistemology, sabda pramana (verbal testimony from an authorised speaker — apta) is a valid source of knowledge. Kusum Thakur's Pratyavartan is a sabda pramana of the highest order: she is the apta, the one whose firsthand knowledge of Lallan Prasad Thakur's creative process authorises her account. No other source — no critical essay, no stage review — can provide what she provides: the knowledge of how each play was written, revised, performed, and received by its first audience (she herself).

The Navya Nyaya tradition's insistence on the reliability conditions of testimony — the apta must be: knowledgeable (jnata), sincere (satya-kama), and not hindered by any incapacity (avisamvadin) — is met fully by Pratyavartan. Kusum Thakur demonstrates knowledge (she was present at all productions), sincerity (the memoir is free of hagiography — she records both the plays' successes and their limitations), and capacity (her writing shows unimpaired analytical and aesthetic judgment).

### *6.2.3 Upadhi (Limiting Condition) in the Rasa Analysis*

Navya Nyaya's concept of upadhi — the limiting condition that qualifies an inference — is useful for understanding the limitations of rasa analysis applied to Lallan Prasad Thakur's plays. The upadhi on the inference 'Nilo Kaka produces karuna rasa' is: only in audiences who share the Maithili cultural context in which Nilo Kaka's social role (the village strongman who protects his community) is understood. Outside that context, the play risks being read purely as comedy (hasya), losing the karuna dimension. This upadhi-analysis explains why the plays were most powerful when staged for their original Jamshedpur / Mithila audiences rather than in metropolitan theatres.

## 6.3 The Epistemological Politics of the Rachanavali

The compilation of the Rachanavali — rescuing Lallan Prasad Thakur's plays from performance memory, photocopies, and scattered individual recollections — is an epistemological act in the Navya Nyaya sense: it transforms perceptual experience (individual audience members' memories of performances) into pratyaksha evidence (verifiable textual record). This transformation from memory to text, from aural-visual to written, is the precondition for systematic pramana (valid knowledge) about the plays — making critical analysis possible where before only anecdotal appreciation existed.

# PART VII: THEMATIC ANALYSIS

## 7.1 The Village-City Divide as Central Theme

All of Lallan Prasad Thakur's major plays are structured around the village-city divide as their central dramatic tension. In Badka Saheb, Chheddi Jha (the village elder) and Chudamani (the village student) are the comic/pathetic representatives of the village world confronting Balchandra Jha's city bungalow. In Nilo Kaka, the protagonist is explicitly a man without land or title who operates in the city through village social capital. In Loangia Miarchai, the village schoolmaster and the professor fight over whether Maithili-medium education (village knowledge) or urban-English education (city knowledge) shall prevail.

This thematic preoccupation is not accidental. Lallan Prasad Thakur was himself a man of this divide: Mithila-born, engineering-educated, TISCO-employed in Jamshedpur — he inhabited the village-city border as a biographical fact. His plays are thus simultaneously autobiography and social analysis.

## 7.2 Political Satire and the Corruption of Power

The political satire of the Nilo Kaka and Badka Saheb plays is direct and specific. Nilo Kaka's encounter with the Minister ('Sunauna Chaudhary, Minister of Rural Development and Education') is a Swiftian savage comedy: the Minister, who cannot even meet Nilo without five rebuffs from a soldier at the gate, represents a government that has completely lost contact with the people it claims to serve. The moment when Nilo bypasses the soldier by shouting in Maithili (provoking a Hindi-speaking system that cannot process Maithili) is the play's most Brechtian moment.

## 7.3 Language as Cultural Identity

The use of Maithili versus Hindi as dramatic choice is never neutral in Lallan Prasad Thakur's plays. The Hindi that the city characters speak (lawyers, officials, the Minister's staff) is associated with power, pretension, and cultural distance. The Maithili of the village characters (Chheddi, Nilo, Ghutar) is associated with wit, authenticity, and social solidarity. The play Maithili Film makes this linguistic politics explicit by staging the aspiration for a cinema in one's own language — a film that does not make Maithili speakers subordinate to Hindi or English.

## 7.4 Gender, Marriage, and Women's Subjectivity — Kusum Thakur

Kusum Thakur's Pratyavartan is remarkable as a feminist document precisely because it does not adopt a feminist rhetorical posture. The child marriage is described without sentimentalism: 'I did not even know what marriage meant.' The negotiation of early married life — learning to wear a sari without stumbling, being displayed to visiting relatives ('Look at how Kusum looks'), being the subject of community inspection — is recorded with a precise ethnographic eye. The memoir's feminist significance lies in what it makes visible: the entire social machinery of patriarchal village culture, described from inside.

Her two poems extend this feminist vision into a lyric mode. Chul Buli Kanya Bani Gelahuṃ is a poem about the recovery of the playful self that patriarchal domesticity had suppressed — the 'mischievous girl' who returns after years of duty and grief. Abhilasha is a meditation on the unfulfilled desire for a daughter — the poem enacts a longing that is itself gendered, since the desire for a daughter rather than a son is already a subversive wish in patriarchal Mithila.

# PART VIII: SYNTHESIS AND CRITICAL ASSESSMENT

## 8.1 Lallan Prasad Thakur's Place in Maithili Theatre History

The formal achievement of Lallan Prasad Thakur's plays rests on three pillars: the mastery of Maithili colloquial dialogue, the sophisticated use of theatrical staging (lighting, projected images, sound), and the construction of characters who are simultaneously local and universal. His Nilo Kaka is as specific as any village elder of Madhubani district and as universal as any political trickster in world literature — a structural achievement that justifies Gangesh Gunjan's comparison with the great figures of the tradition.

The systematic neglect of his work by the Sahitya Akademi — during his lifetime and after his death — is explicable within the Videha Parallel History Framework as a function of the same caste-based cultural gatekeeping that denied Harimohan Jha (the greatest Maithili satirist) the Akademi award that the year 1967 went without rather than award to him. The publication of the Rachanavali in 2022, twenty-seven years after Lallan Prasad Thakur's death, is a partial correction of this institutional injustice.

## 8.2 Kusum Thakur's Independent Contribution

Kusum Thakur must be evaluated not only as a literary widow and curator of her husband's memory but as an independent literary figure. Pratyavartan is a memoir of the first rank in Maithili prose — comparable in its social texture and emotional honesty to the best autobiographical writing in any modern Indian language. Her poems, though brief, demonstrate a lyric gift independent of her husband's theatrical achievement.

Her role as first critic and collaborator in the development of every play — acknowledged in the Rachanavali's preface and in her memoir — also constitutes a creative contribution that criticism has not adequately acknowledged. The concept of the invisible collaborator — the partner whose intellectual and emotional labour shapes a creative work without appearing in the credits — is a recurrent feminist critical concern. Kusum Thakur's contribution to Maithili theatre deserves its own sustained critical attention.

## 8.3 Conclusion: The Civilisational Significance

Assessed through Bharata Muni's Natyashastra (rasa, abhinaya, the democratic mandate of drama); Brecht's epic theatre (Verfremdungseffekt, the political song); Stanislavski's psychological realism; Brook's empty space; Boal's theatre of the oppressed; Bakhtin's carnivalesque and heteroglossia; Gramsci's organic intellectual; Fanon's cultural decolonisation; Anandavardhana's dhvani; Kuntaka's vakrokti; Abhinavagupta's sadharanikarana; Gilbert & Gubar's feminist criticism; and Gangesh Upadhyaya's Navya Nyaya — Lallan Prasad Thakur emerges as one of the significant figures of 20th-century Maithili drama, and Kusum Thakur as an important literary witness and independent voice whose full contribution has yet to be critically assessed.

Their combined legacy — twelve years of theatrical production, a memoir of civilisational depth, a handful of lyric poems, and the work of archival recovery — constitutes a contribution to Maithili cultural life that the Videha movement's publication of the Rachanavali and Sadeha 34 is the first step in adequately honouring.

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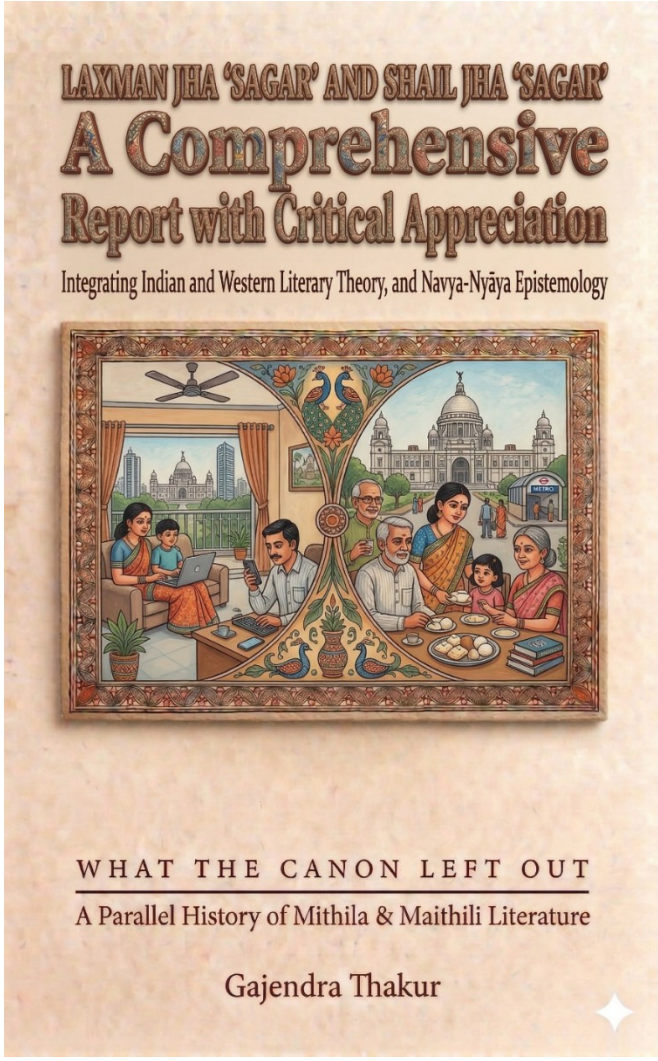

# LAXMAN JHA 'SAGAR' AND SHAIL JHA 'SAGAR'

*A Comprehensive Research Report with Critical Appreciation*

*Integrating Indian and Western Literary Theory, and Navya-Nyāya Epistemology*

## Abstract

This research report offers a comprehensive critical study of two significant contributors to contemporary Maithili literature: Laxman Jha 'Sagar' (born 1 April 1953, Dhakbahtiya, Ghoghardiha, Madhubani, Bihar) and his wife Shail Jha 'Sagar', a poet-writer in her own right. Drawing primarily from Videha e-Journal's special issue No. 382 (15 November 2023) dedicated to Laxman Jha 'Sagar', and supplemented by broader web sources, this report examines their literary contributions across multiple genres — poetry, short story, interview-collection, varta-katha, and critical essay — within the parallel literary tradition of Maithili. The report critically appreciates their work through a syncretic framework drawing on (i) Indian aesthetic theory (Rasa, Dhvani, Vakrokti); (ii) Western critical theory (New Criticism, Post-Colonial theory, Reader-Response, Feminist theory); and (iii) the Navya-Nyāya epistemology of Gangesa Upadhyaya (14th century, Mithila), with its pramāṇa-based analysis (pratyakṣa, anumāna, upamāna, śabda) applied as a framework for evaluating literary truth-claims and the authenticity of literary testimony. The report argues that both writers exemplify a committed, place-rooted literary practice in the tradition of Babu Saheb Choudhary's Mithila-Maithili movement, deploying satire, social realism, and linguistic authenticity as modes of resistance and cultural preservation.

Contents: 1. Introduction and Background | 2. Biographical Profiles | 3. The Videha Literary Tradition | 4. Published Works and Genres | 5. Critical Appreciation: Indian Frameworks | 6. Critical Appreciation: Western Frameworks | 7. Critical Appreciation: Navya-Nyāya Epistemology | 8. Shail Jha 'Sagar': A Feminist Reading | 9. The Literary Partnership | 10. Reception and Significance | 11. Conclusion | 12. References

# 1. Introduction and Background

## 1.1 The Maithili Literary Landscape

Maithili, one of India's 22 constitutionally scheduled languages (admitted to the Eighth Schedule in 2003 under Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee), is one of South Asia's oldest literary languages. Its literary tradition extends back to at least the 12th century CE, with the poet Jyotirishwar Thakur (c. 1290–1350) authoring 'Varnaratnakara', considered the first prose encyclopedia in any north Indian language. The tradition reached its classical apex with the poet Vidyapati (c. 1352–1448), the 'Maithil Kavi Kokil,' whose padavali influenced Bengali, Odia, and Assamese literary traditions and whose linguistic position has been compared — both by scholars and by writers in the Videha movement — to that of Dante in Italy or Chaucer in England.

Contemporary Maithili literature must be understood within the context of a centuries-long struggle for linguistic recognition, institutional support, and the preservation of Tirhuta (Mithilakshara) script alongside Devanagari. The Maithili literary revival of the 19th–20th centuries was catalysed by journals such as Mithila Mihir and Mithila Darshan (Calcutta), by the organizational work of figures such as Babu Saheb Choudhary, and by the scholarship of figures like Dr. Jayakant Mishra. The inclusion of Maithili in the Eighth Schedule gave constitutional recognition but did not resolve questions of primary-school medium of instruction, state patronage, or the digital preservation of the language.

It is within this contested, richly historical context that Laxman Jha 'Sagar' has spent more than five decades as writer, cultural activist, and institutional memory-keeper. His significance lies not only in his literary output — which spans poetry, short fiction, interview-anthology, and critical essay — but in his embodied commitment to the cause as a diasporic Maithili living in Kolkata's industrial-commercial milieu, far from the heartland of Mithila in Bihar and Nepal's Terai region.

## 1.2 Videha e-Journal and the Parallel Tradition

The primary source for this report is Videha e-Journal (ISSN 2229-547X), edited by Gajendra Thakur and available at www.videha.co.in. Videha is the

first and longest-running Maithili-language fortnightly e-journal, having originated as 'Bhalsarik Gachh', the first Maithili blog, on 5 July 2004, and rechristened as Videha from 1 January 2008. It has published over 390 issues and has been instrumental in digitally preserving and promoting Maithili literature across all genres, with particular emphasis on what it terms the 'parallel tradition' — literary voices that fall outside the mainstream academic and governmental patronage networks of institutions such as Sahitya Akademi, Delhi, or the Maithili Akademi, Patna.

The parallel tradition, as articulated by Videha's editorial philosophy, references the counterculture of Maithili letters: voices that address the quotidian, the socially critical, the provincial-yet-cosmopolitan experience of Maithili-speaking communities in diaspora — in Kolkata, Guwahati, Mumbai, Delhi, and abroad. Laxman Jha 'Sagar' is both a product and a champion of this tradition.

## 2. Biographical Profiles

### 2.1 Laxman Jha 'Sagar': Life and Formation

Laxman Jha 'Sagar' was born on 1 April 1953 in the village of Dhakbahtiya, Ghoghardiha, Madhubani district, Bihar. His father was Sri Tarkeshwar Jha (also known as Sri Bhola Jha); his mother was Smt. Ganga Devi. He spent much of his childhood in his maternal home at Belaunchha. His grandfather served as Headmaster of Tamuriya High School and subscribed to Mithila Mihir, Aryavarta, and Indian Nation newspapers, ensuring that the household was saturated with literary and nationalist culture from early childhood.

Sagar's first published work appeared in Hindi in 1968 in 'Aryavarta'; in the same year his first Maithili composition was published in 'Mithila Mihir'. This dual early debut — in Hindi and Maithili, in the same year, at age fifteen — is emblematic of his subsequent career: a writer deeply committed to Maithili, yet fully bilingual, operating across linguistic borders without surrendering the priority of the mother tongue.

Sagar came to Kolkata on 1 January 1974 to pursue Chartered Accountancy, residing initially in the hostel at Raja Bazaar. The trajectory of his Kolkata years was profoundly shaped by his relationship with Babu Saheb Choudhary (full name: Babu Saheb Choudhary), the patriarch of Kolkata's Mithila-Maithili

movement. When Sagar's CA studies were interrupted by financial hardship — he was evicted from his lodging on the night of 19 September 1974 — Choudhary intervened directly, securing accommodation and support. This encounter consolidated Sagar's lifelong alignment with Choudhary's philosophy of cultural-linguistic activism over institutional careerism.

From 1983 to 1997 Sagar worked in Guwahati, Assam, where he not only continued his literary work but founded 'Mithila Sanskritik Samanvay Samiti' and associated with the founding of 'Purvattar Maithil', Assamese Maithili's first colour-printed quarterly journal — under the leadership of the late Satyanand Pathak and Sri Premkant Choudhary. This period in Assam, including the threat of ULFA (United Liberation Front of Asom) militancy against him, tested his resolution and ultimately led to his return to Kolkata in 1997. There he joined Neo Metaliks (a company in the Rupa & Co. group), from which he retired as Senior Purchase Manager in 2012 but continued as consultant. His permanent address is 3B, Tista Apartment, 94 Avenue South Road, Santoshpur, Kolkata-65.

Sagar holds the CA (Inter) qualification, First Group (1976). He has received twelve major literary and cultural honours between 2017 and 2023, including the Babu Saheb Choudhary Samman (Akhil Bharatiya Mithila Sangh, Delhi, 2017), the Dr. Inrarkant Jha Samman (Vidyapati Seva Sansthan, Darbhanga, 2018), and the Mithila Vibhuti Samman (Karnataka Mithila Sanskritik Manch, Bengaluru, 2022), recognising both his literary work and his institutional contributions to the Maithili cause.

## 2.2 Shail Jha 'Sagar': Profile and Significance

Shail Jha 'Sagar' (née: family name Thakur before marriage) is both a writer in Maithili in her own right and the life-partner of Laxman Jha 'Sagar'. The Videha special issue makes explicit its editorial rationale for including her work: within Maithili literary culture there exists a notable tradition of literary couples (dampati lekhak), and Shail Jha is one of its living representatives. Her inclusion also reflects an important feminist-editorial principle: if hundreds of pages can be devoted to the male writer, then a few pages devoted to the woman who has been equally present — as co-creator, first reader, and independent author — is not a supplement but a correction.

Shail Jha's work presented in the Videha special issue spans three genres: a short story ('Pati Parmeshwar' — 'The Husband as God'), a literary letter-cum-review ('Ekta Patra: Ekta Samiksha — Kist Kist Jivan' — 'One Letter: One Review — Life in Instalments'), and a poem ('Beti' — 'Daughter'). These three

pieces together constitute a remarkably coherent feminist voice, addressing in different registers the constraints of patriarchal expectation, the loneliness of the elderly, and the paradoxical status of daughters in Maithili society.

Shail Jha is described by multiple contributors to the Videha issue as a 'sagar pathika' — an attentive reader of Maithili literature — and as a co-participant in the cultural-activist dimension of Sagar's work. As Nabonarayan Mishra notes, Sagar's family home is distinguished by its exclusive use of Maithili as the domestic language — a remarkable commitment given that the family lives in a Bengali-dominant metropolitan environment.

## 3. The Videha Literary Context and the Babu Saheb Choudhary Tradition

Laxman Jha 'Sagar's literary identity is inseparable from the organizational and ideological legacy of Babu Saheb Choudhary, whose philosophy he invokes repeatedly in his autobiography and whose collected memorial volume he was preparing at the time of this publication. Babu Saheb Choudhary (whose full name appears in different forms in the sources) was the founding figure of Kolkata's Maithili literary and political mobilization, pioneering the publication of Mithila Darshan and engaging prime ministers in the cause of Maithili recognition. His dictum — quoted by Sagar — that an organization which neither agitates nor creates literature is a mere 'kirtaniya-mandali' (singing troupe) remains one of Sagar's foundational critical principles.

This tradition continues in the Videha movement's parallel literary philosophy. Gajendra Thakur's Videha project, which began in 2000 and was formally launched as a fortnightly e-journal in 2008, represents the digital culmination of this tradition: decentralized, non-institutional, committed to all voices regardless of caste, gender, or geography, and technically innovative in its use of both Devanagari and Tirhuta (Mithilakshara) scripts, Unicode, and Braille. It is significant that Gangesa Upadhyaya — the 14th-century logician of Mithila whose Tattvachintamani founded the Navya-Nyāya school — appears in Videha's discourse not only as a historical figure but as a legitimating ancestor: Gajendra Thakur authored the Maithili short story 'Shabdashastram' (The Science of Words), based on true Panji records of Gangesa Upadhyaya, which was translated into English and published in Sahitya Akademi's Indian Literature journal (Vol. 58, No. 2, 2014). This suggests that the Videha

movement consciously situates itself within the deep epistemological tradition of Mithila.

# 4. Published Works and Genres

## 4.1 Laxman Jha 'Sagar': Published Works

Sagar's published literary corpus comprises four books:

(1) Uchharr Baisu Kaua (Sit Down, Crow! — Poetry Collection, 2010): His debut collection, published from Guwahati. The title — an injunction to a crow to perch — is deliberately anti-lyrical, subverting the classical Maithili poetic convention of the koil (cuckoo) as the emblem of the literary voice. The choice of the crow signals Sagar's allegiance to the everyday, the blunt, the unheroic — a poetics of social realism over aestheticized romanticism.

(2) Ekah Gadhbere Me (At the Same Jackfruit Time — Poetry Collection, 2020): His second collection, whose title again employs a demotic temporal idiom ('gadhber' = the time of eating jackfruit, a colloquial evening hour) to anchor the lyric in the specific rhythms of Maithili rural-urban life.

(3) Nisoh (Varta-Katha, 2021): A collection of varta-katha, a hybrid Maithili genre that blends the conversational story, the anecdote, and the social essay. The title 'Nisoh' (loosely: 'without support' or 'independent') gestures toward the solitary integrity of the moral and literary witness.

(4) Jena O Kahlakan (As They Said — Interview Collection, 2021): A collection of seven extended interviews with major figures of the Maithili movement: Babu Saheb Choudhary (31 Dec 1976), Dr. Jayakant Mishra (21 July 1979), Sri Pitambar Pathak (7 Oct 2001), Sri Rajnandan Lal Das, Dr. Virender Malik, Sri Mahendra Malangiya, and Sri Ashok Jha. These interviews, conducted without tape recorder or notes — drawn from memory and later transcribed — document the institutional, political, and literary history of the Maithili movement across five decades.

Additionally, Sagar has extensive unpublished manuscripts including essay collections, memoirs, story collections, a literary criticism volume, and a biography collection. He has served twice as guest editor of 'Purvattar Maithil' (the Maithili quarterly published from Guwahati) and has been editor of a memorial volume for Babu Saheb Choudhary.

### 4.2 Shail Jha 'Sagar': Works Presented

The three works published in the Videha special issue represent three distinct registers of Shail Jha's authorial identity. 'Pati Parmeshwar' (The Husband as God) is a short story set in urban Kolkata, tracing the parallel loneliness of an elderly woman (Kaki) and the narrator through the lens of changing family structures. The story's social-realist mode and understated irony (the title is a traditional phrase that the story quietly interrogates through the figure of an old woman abandoned by successful sons) places it squarely within the Maithili progressive short-story tradition.

The letter-essay 'Ekta Patra: Ekta Samiksha — Kist Kist Jivan' is addressed to the autobiographical author of 'Kist Kist Jivan' (Life in Instalments), and operates as both review and confession. Shail Jha writes that reading the book moved her to uncontrollable tears from the first page; she calls it a 'viral rachna' (rare composition) and urges its translation into international languages. This piece demonstrates a sophisticated reader-response: the letter locates its emotional authority precisely in the domestic, feminine position ('a household woman reading it') that literary criticism often marginalizes.

The poem 'Beti' (Daughter) is structured as an eight-stanza refrain poem: 'Ham beti chhi, ham beti chhi / Ham ahi samaajak beti chhi' (I am a daughter, I am a daughter / I am daughter of this very society). Each stanza enumerates a social role — the beloved ('dulri'), the playmate of brothers, the daughter-in-law locked in a trunk — before concluding with the paradox that without daughters there is no son, no path to heaven, yet daughters remain the least-valued. The poem is formally simple but socially sharp, exemplifying what feminist critics of Indian poetry have termed 'subversive domesticity'.

## 5. Critical Appreciation: Indian Literary Frameworks

### 5.1 Rasa Theory (Bharatamuni / Abhinavagupta)

Classical Indian aesthetics from Bharatamuni's Natyashastra onwards organizes literary experience around rasa: the aesthetic emotions (shringara-love, hasya-comedy, karuna-pathos, vira-heroism, etc.) that are universalized from specific emotional states (sthayibhava) through the transaction of vibhava

(determinants), anubhava (consequents), and vyabhicharibhava (transitory states). Abhinavagupta's 10th-century elaboration in Abhinavabharati locates rasa as a form of brahmananda — not mere pleasure but a form of spiritual universalization of the self through the literary object.

Laxman Jha 'Sagar's poetry is predominantly governed by karuna (pathos), vira (heroism of language and social commitment), and hasya shading into satira (satirical comedy). In 'Uchharr Baisu Kaua', the crow — as emblem of the overlooked, the scavenging intelligence, the unheroic commentator — provokes a karuna-vira synthesis: the pathos of cultural marginalization channelled into the heroic act of writing in and for the mother tongue. The poem extract cited by Surendra Thakur — 'Sahityak thekedar jahan faank bhi jaai chhai / Tan bad dukh hoyi chhai' (When the literary contractor's book becomes a wastepaper / Then great sorrow comes) — deploys hasya to produce a karuna that is politically activated: the pathos is not passive but functions as protest.

Shail Jha's 'Beti' operates through sthayibhava of shoka (grief-sorrow) but its refrain structure — 'Ham beti chhi' — converts private grief into collective assertion. Abhinavagupta's concept of sadharanikarana (universalization, the literary mechanism by which particular emotion becomes universal) is precisely what this poem achieves: the speaker's 'I am a daughter' becomes every daughter's statement, and the poem's emotional resonance in performance (it is designed for recitation) confirms this universalizing function.

## 5.2 Dhvani and Vakrokti

Anandavardhana's Dhvanyaloka (9th century) argues that the soul of poetry lies in dhvani — the resonant suggestion that exceeds the literal meaning. Kuntaka's Vakroktijivita (10th century) locates poetic power in vakrokti — the oblique expression that deviates from the ordinary (svabhavokti) through deliberate aesthetic choice.

Sagar's varta-katha in 'Nisoh' exemplifies the dhvani principle: the surface is that of a quiet, often humorous anecdote, but the suggested meaning — the erosion of Maithili culture, the betrayal of the language by its own educated class — reverberates beneath every domestic scene. Similarly, the title 'Nisoh' operates dhvanically: the word's literal meaning (without support) suggests both the author's solitary position and the condition of the language itself.

The title 'Uchharr Baisu Kaua' demonstrates vakrokti at the macro-structural level: the whole book is a vakrokta — a literarily deviant utterance — because

it displaces the classical Maithili kavi (poet) who addresses the kokil (cuckoo) with a plain man who addresses the kaua (crow). This structural irony operates as what Kuntaka would call 'vakrokti in genre selection': the deviation from convention is itself the vehicle of meaning.

### 5.3 Riti and the Question of Linguistic Authenticity

The Riti school (Vamana, 8th century) evaluates poetry through the excellence of its linguistic style (riti) — defined not as ornamentation alone but as the coalescence of guna (qualities: clarity, sweetness, force) with alankar. Multiple contributors to the Videha special issue praise Sagar's Maithili for its deployment of ṭheṭha (core, pure) Maithili vocabulary — the endangered lexical stratum of rural, pre-urbanized Maithili that is disappearing under the pressure of Hindi and Bengali. As Surendra Thakur writes in his extended critical appreciation, Sagar deliberately excavates 'herayal-bhutiaayal shabd' (lost and forgotten words) — reclaiming them for literary use and thereby performing an act of linguistic preservation through aesthetic practice. This is Riti theory applied to a socio-political context: the qualities of Maithili writing are inseparable from the political question of which Maithili is written.

## 6. Critical Appreciation: Western Literary Frameworks

### 6.1 New Criticism and Close Reading

The New Critical paradigm (I.A. Richards, Cleanth Brooks, Robert Penn Warren) insists on the autonomy of the literary text and the centrality of close reading — attending to irony, paradox, tension, and the organic unity of form and content. Applied to Sagar's poetry, New Criticism reveals a sophisticated management of tonal paradox: the crow-poem's surface bluntness contains layers of self-conscious irony about the social position of the writer. In 'Ekah Gadhbere Me', the domestic temporal marker ('gadhber' time) performs a kind of New Critical 'tension' — between the urgency of social address and the deliberate, unhurried cadence of domestic time.

Shail Jha's 'Beti' rewards New Critical attention to its refrain structure: the identity phrase 'Ham beti chhi' does not simply repeat — it accumulates. With each stanza, the daughter is a 'dulri', then a 'bhurli', then a 'toki jaka', then a

locked-up 'peti' (trunk), then a 'hira moti' (pearl and diamond), then a 'roṭi' — food itself, the sustainer. The poem's paradox: the daughter is simultaneously the most precious and the most consumed. The New Critical unity consists in this paradox being not resolved but held in productive tension.

## 6.2 Post-Colonial Theory

Homi Bhabha's concept of the 'third space' — the liminal cultural space produced by colonial encounter and its afterlives — is illuminating for understanding the position of the diasporic Maithili writer in Kolkata. Sagar inhabits a third space between Mithila (the origin, the cultural homeland) and the Bengali-dominant metropolis. His writing is neither fully rooted in Mithila's classical literary tradition nor accommodated within the dominant cultural-linguistic system of Kolkata. It is precisely this third space — where the mother tongue is maintained against dominant-language pressure, where Maithili is spoken at home in a Bengali city — that generates the political and literary charge of his work.

Frantz Fanon's analysis in 'The Wretched of the Earth' of the intellectual who returns from the colonial metropole to reclaim the suppressed language and culture is also relevant: Sagar's career narrative — CA student abandoning professional advancement for cultural activism, returning repeatedly to Maithili organizations, using his industrial corporate position as a resource for cultural work rather than an alternative to it — mirrors Fanon's 'native intellectual' who turns from European models to rediscover and reinvent the national culture.

Edward Said's concept of 'affiliation' versus 'filiation' offers a further lens: Sagar's literary identity is built on affiliation — a chosen loyalty to the Maithili tradition and the Babu Saheb Choudhary legacy — rather than mere filiation (inherited belonging). This makes his commitment epistemologically stronger and politically more conscious.

## 6.3 Reader-Response Theory

Wolfgang Iser's concept of the 'implied reader' — the reader constructed by the text — and Stanley Fish's notion of 'interpretive communities' are useful for understanding the specific readership that Sagar's work both addresses and constructs. His writing presupposes an ideal reader who is: (i) Maithili-literate in both Devanagari and ideally Tirhuta; (ii) aware of the cultural-political stakes of the language; (iii) living in diaspora and therefore particularly sensitive to the erosion of linguistic identity; and (iv) committed to what Sagar calls

'sachcha Maithili' — genuine, engaged Maithili writing as opposed to institutional performance.

Shail Jha's letter-essay to Shefalika (author of 'Kist Kist Jivan') performs a meta-reader-response criticism: it is itself an account of reading, of how a text operates on a specific reader (a 'gharelo mahila', household woman) in a specific context (during the Mahakumbh period, as neighbours go on pilgrimage). This meta-critical move — criticism as enacted reading — anticipates the concerns of contemporary Reader-Response theory while remaining embedded in a specifically Maithili domestic-literary context.

## 6.4 Feminist Theory

Sandra Gilbert and Susan Gubar's concept of the 'anxiety of authorship' — the specific pressure on women writers who must negotiate a patriarchal literary tradition that does not recognize their subjectivity — applies directly to Shail Jha's literary position. The Videha editorial team's explicit justification for including her work — 'if hundreds of pages can be devoted to the man, why can't a few pages be devoted to the woman who has been equally present?' — reveals exactly the structural marginalization that feminist theory describes. Shail Jha's three texts collectively negotiate this position: the short story critiques patriarchal family structures (the 'pati-parmeshwar' principle); the letter performs intellectual authority through domestic positioning ('I, a household woman, read this before my husband'); and the poem names and interrogates the daughter's condition directly.

Elaine Showalter's concept of 'gynocriticism' — the study of women's literature as a distinct tradition — suggests that Shail Jha's work should be read not only in relation to her husband's oeuvre but as part of the tradition of Maithili women's writing that includes figures like Chandrakala Devi, Rajni Anil, and the growing cohort of women writers in Videha's pages. Her three pieces demonstrate formal range and thematic coherence that merits independent critical attention.

# 7. Critical Appreciation: Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gangesa Upadhyaya

## 7.1 Gangesa Upadhyaya and the Tattvachintamani

Gangesa Upadhyaya (c. first half of 14th century) was born and lived in the Mithila region — specifically in the village of Karion, twelve miles southeast of Darbhanga — and is thus a specifically Maithili intellectual ancestor. His Tattvachintamani ('The Jewel of Reflection on Truth about Epistemology') founded the Navya-Nyāya ('New Logic') school and remained the foundational text of Indian logic and epistemology through the 18th century. As Keith observed, 'the logic of Nyāya attained its final shape' through Gangesa's work, and as Radhakrishnan noted, every system of Hindu thought accepts the fundamental principles of Nyāya logic and uses Nyāya terminology even when criticizing it.

The Tattvachintamani is organized around the four pramāṇas — valid sources of knowledge: pratyakṣa (perception), anumāna (inference), upamāna (comparison/analogy), and śabda (testimony/word). Gangesa's significant innovation was to treat epistemology and logic as the primary philosophical disciplines, 'divesting Nyāya of its metaphysical appendages.' He also advanced an 'extrinsicality' thesis: although putative perceptions are automatically taken as veridical, their confirmation as genuine knowledge requires a separate cognitive act. This means that knowledge-claims must be tested against external criteria — a profoundly critical epistemological stance.

Crucially, the Navya-Nyāya of Mithila later influenced the development of methodology across Sanskrit disciplines including grammar, poetics (Kavya-Sahitya), and other darshanas. The application of Navya-Nyāya methodology to literary criticism is therefore not a mere methodological transplant but a historically grounded possibility — one that the Videha movement itself implicitly acknowledges through Gajendra Thakur's 'Shabdashastram' story.

## 7.2 Pratyakṣa (Perception) and Literary Testimony

In Navya-Nyāya, pratyakṣa (perception) is the most direct pramāṇa: veridical cognition arising from direct sensory contact with an object. Applied to literary criticism, the pratyakṣa criterion asks: does the work present experience in a manner that commands immediate assent — does it feel true? This is closely related to what Wordsworth called 'the spontaneous overflow of powerful feelings recollected in tranquillity' and what Keats theorized as 'negative

capability': the capacity to hold uncertainty without reaching after fact or reason.

Sagar's autobiographical essay ('Apan Aatmakathya') demonstrates high pratyakṣa validity: the specific, named, dated account of his early life in Kolkata — the eviction on the night of 19 September 1974, sleeping hungry, walking on foot with a chest on his head to the Rajendra Hostel, weeping before the Kali temple — carries the phenomenological vividness of direct sensory recall. The Navya-Nyāya critic would say that such writing generates cognition of the anubhava kind (consequent emotion) that confirms the vibhava (causal circumstance) as genuine: the reader does not merely believe these events happened but perceives their truth through the writing.

Shail Jha's 'Pati Parmeshwar' demonstrates similar pratyakṣa quality: the story's Kolkata domestic setting — the multi-floor apartment, the son working in Delhi and Bangalore, the medical episodes of the ageing couple — is rendered with the specificity of direct observation. The narrative detail of Kaki's knee injury, the son who sends money but does not return, the doctor's instruction to avoid stress: these are recognitions, not inventions.

## 7.3 Anumāna (Inference) and the Social-Critical Mode

Anumāna in Nyāya is inferential cognition based on the vyapti — the universal pervasion or invariable concomitance between a hetu (reason/mark) and the sadhya (probandum). The classic form: 'There is fire on the hill because there is smoke, and where there is smoke there is fire.' Applied to literature, anumāna becomes the mechanism by which the text moves from the particular to the general, from the individual case to the social law.

Sagar's satirical mode — what multiple contributors to the Videha issue identify as his nishedhatmak (critical-negative) mode — operates through social anumāna. In 'Ekah Gadhbere Me', the poem fragment 'Sahityak thekedar' (literary contractor) infers from the particular observation (contractor's books becoming wastepaper) to a general social probandum: the corruption of Maithili literary institutions by careerist self-interest. The hetu (specific symptom) licenses the anumāna (general diagnosis). This is what makes Sagar's satire not mere personal complaint but social analysis.

Similarly, Shail Jha's poem 'Beti' moves through anumāna: from the particular enumeration of a daughter's social roles (hetu) to the invariable conclusion (sadhya) that daughters are both essential and undervalued in this society — a

vyapti (universal concomitance) that the poem establishes as social law through accumulated evidence.

## 7.4 Upamāna (Comparison/Analogy) and Intertextual Meaning

Upamāna in Nyāya is the pramāṇa of comparison — knowledge arising from the recognition of similarity between an unfamiliar object and a familiar one. In literary terms, upamāna operates through simile, metaphor, and intertextual reference.

The most striking upamāna in the Videha special issue is Sagar's own title: 'Uchharr Baisu Kaua' (Sit Down, Crow!). The crow is placed in comparative relation to the canonical Maithili kokil (cuckoo) — but via antithesis: the hitherto unfamiliar (the crow-poet) is recognized through similarity-with-difference to the familiar (the cuckoo-poet). This meta-poetic upamāna establishes Sagar's entire aesthetic programme as 'oppositional comparison': his writing is like classical Maithili poetry insofar as it is poetry — and unlike it in every substantive respect.

Shail Jha's letter performs upamāna explicitly: 'Sagar Ji aahaan tak tulna Mahadevi Verma, Mahasweta Devi vagairah sain karait chhi' (Sagar [meaning her husband Laxman] compares you [Shefalika] to Mahadevi Verma and Mahasweta Devi). The comparison is a pramāṇa for the value of 'Kist Kist Jivan' — its validity derived from recognized excellence in comparable literary figures.

## 7.5 Śabda (Testimony) and the Authority of the Interview Tradition

Śabda in Navya-Nyāya is the pramāṇa of linguistic testimony — knowledge derived from reliable, authoritative utterance. Gangesa's analysis of śabda is particularly nuanced: he distinguishes between the reliability of the speaker (vaktr-visvasa) and the well-formedness of the utterance (shabda-tatparya), arguing that śabda is valid only when both conditions are met. This has direct implications for Sagar's most significant literary project: 'Jena O Kahlakan' (As They Said).

The interview collection is built entirely on śabda — the testimony of seven major figures of the Maithili movement, recorded from memory (significantly, without tape recorder or written notes at the time of utterance) and later reconstructed as written text. The Navya-Nyāya critic must evaluate: (i) Were the witnesses (Babu Saheb Choudhary, Dr. Jayakant Mishra, et al.) reliable

(apta) — authoritative speakers whose testimony is varidical? The answer is clearly yes: these are recognized figures, identified by name and institutional affiliation. (ii) Is Sagar's mediation of their words a faithful act of transmission? Hitanath Jha's review in the Videha issue addresses this directly: he notes that the interviews were reconstructed without mechanical recording, making Sagar's cognitive integrity the sole guarantee of their accuracy. The Navya-Nyāya framework suggests we assess this through anumāna: the consistency, specificity, and cross-verifiable details in these accounts provide evidential grounds for their reliability.

This epistemological question — whether literary testimony, transmitted through human memory and reconstructed through writing, constitutes valid śabda — is not merely academic. It is central to the entire project of the parallel Maithili literary tradition, which has often been preserved through oral transmission and personal memory when institutional archives and official records were absent or inaccessible. Sagar's interview method performs, at the literary-methodological level, exactly what Gangesa's Navya-Nyāya performs at the epistemological level: a rigorous examination of the conditions under which transmitted knowledge can be trusted.

## 7.6 The Extrinsicality Thesis and Literary Self-Correction

Gangesa's 'extrinsicality' (paratahpramanya) thesis holds that knowledge's validity is not self-certifying but requires external confirmation — though putative cognitions are automatically taken as true in ordinary life. This provides a critical tool for evaluating the reception of Sagar's work. Several contributors to the Videha special issue note that Sagar 'divides opinion': his directness, his tendency toward frank criticism of persons and institutions, his uncompromising advocacy of Maithili has made him some adversaries. The Navya-Nyāya extrinsicality thesis suggests that this is not merely a social phenomenon but an epistemological one: the reception of committed literary testimony requires external criteria — institutional recognition, independent corroboration, the passage of time — to move from presumptive acceptance to confirmed knowledge-claim. The multiple awards from diverse institutions (Delhi, Darbhanga, Kolkata, Bengaluru, Ahmedabad) constitute exactly such external confirmation, validating through collective social agreement what was initially a individually-asserted literary position.

## 8. Shail Jha 'Sagar': A Feminist Reading

Reading Shail Jha's work as an independent corpus, rather than as an appendage to her husband's, reveals a writer who navigates the specific contradictions of the educated middle-class Maithili woman in urban diaspora. Her three pieces collectively address three axes of feminine constraint:

(1) The generational axis ('Pati Parmeshwar'): Kaki embodies the woman who has organized her life around the traditional patriarchal contract — husband first, sons second, self never. The story's quiet subversion is that this contract has failed her: the sons are in Delhi and Bangalore, the grandchildren in 'crèche', and Kaki — who has done everything right — is alone. The protagonist-narrator observes this with a complexity that is neither sentimental nor bitter: she draws an analogy between Kaki's situation and that of the 'Parmeshwar' (servant) who fifty years ago worked alongside his wife in the fields as equals. The story's political point — that the 'backward caste' worker has a more humane domestic partnership than the successful nuclear family of the educated middle class — is made through juxtaposition, not argument.

(2) The domestic-intellectual axis ('Ekta Patra'): Shail Jha's letter claims the authority of the domestic reader — 'a household woman' — as a literary-critical subject. This is a deliberate feminist move: she positions her reading of 'Kist Kist Jivan' not despite but through her domestic position. 'Gharelu naari hevak karane e labh ham uṭhailung, hunkaa sar pahine hamheen padhi gailung' (Being a household woman, I took this benefit; I read it before him). The domestic is reframed as a site of literary knowledge, not its absence.

(3) The structural axis ('Beti'): The poem addresses the daughter's paradoxical position in a formal register that moves between the lyric and the social essay. The refrain 'Ham beti chhi, ham ahi samaajak beti chhi' becomes increasingly ironic as the poem accumulates the daughter's roles: she is precious ('hira moti'), yet locked in a trunk; she is food ('roṭi'), yet without her there is no heaven. The poem's feminist achievement is to make the contradiction visible and audible without offering a facile resolution — the refrain at the end is not triumph but statement.

This analysis suggests that Shail Jha's literary identity deserves a dedicated scholarly study, one that situates her within the tradition of Maithili women's writing alongside Lilawati Devi, Usha Kiran Khan, and Vibha Rani, and within the broader context of South Asian women's literature in regional languages.

## 9. The Literary Partnership: Dampati Lekhak

The concept of the 'dampati lekhak' (literary couple) has a notable if understudied history in Maithili literature. The Videha editorial note explicitly locates the Sagars within this tradition. What makes their partnership distinctive is its organizational as well as literary dimension: Sagar maintains a strict personal rule that he will not attend any literary function without Shail Jha (as Kameshwar Jha 'Kamal' notes approvingly: 'He made a rule: if I go to any literary programme, I will not go without Shail Ji'). This is not a mere social convention but an implicit feminist commitment — the refusal to be visible in the public sphere of literature without simultaneously making the woman writer's presence required.

In Navya-Nyāya terms, this practice performs a form of vyapti (universal concomitance) at the social level: wherever Sagar appears as a literary actor, Shail Jha is also present — not as accompaniment but as co-presence. Over decades, this sustained co-presence has contributed to a normalization of women's participation in Maithili literary events that has broader cultural consequences.

Multiple contributors to the Videha special issue invoke the formula: 'Sagar Ji ki safaltaa mein unki dharmapatni Shail Jha 'Sagar' Ji ka pramukh yogdan rahlak chhi' (In Sagar Ji's success, his wife Shail Jha 'Sagar's contribution has been primary). This acknowledgment, made by men writing in tribute to a male writer, is itself a significant feminist gesture within the conventions of the genre.

## 10. Reception and Significance

The critical reception of Laxman Jha 'Sagar' in the Videha special issue is unanimously positive but not uncritical. Several contributors offer assessments that correspond to what Navya-Nyāya would call 'motivated cognition' (the sahridaya's favorable reading) as well as to more distanced evaluation. Virendr Jha identifies Sagar as a 'spashtvadi sahityakar' (plain-speaking writer) whose social-realist mode, sociological content (joint family dissolution, elder neglect, caste and social custom), and commitment to upcoming writers constitute a distinctive contribution. Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil' locates the

interview collection 'Jena O Kahlakan' as a document of unique historical importance — an archive of oral testimony from seven figures whose first-hand accounts of the Maithili movement's institutional history would otherwise be lost.

Chandana Datt offers perhaps the most balanced appreciation: she praises Sagar's 'nibhik, spasht aur imandar lekhnee' (fearless, clear, honest writing) while situating it within the socio-political context of Maithili in Kolkata — the Bengali-dominant metropolis where Maithili speakers are constantly pressured to abandon their linguistic identity.

Vibha Rani's account is distinctive in its focus on personality: she notes Sagar's personal warmth, his insistence on making time for literary encounters, his colourful kurtas (shirts), his resistance to the social expectation that elderly men should wear dull clothes and recite prayers at home — a small but telling detail of a personality that refuses the shrinkage of age.

As of 2023, Sagar's standing in the Maithili literary world is as a figure who has received recognition from institutions spanning the full geographic range of the Maithili diaspora — Delhi, Darbhanga, Kolkata, Bengaluru, Ahmedabad — suggesting a national significance that transcends regional or factional alignments. His planned memorial volume for Babu Saheb Choudhary is awaited as a significant contribution to the institutional history of the movement.

## 11. Conclusion

Laxman Jha 'Sagar' represents a model of the committed regional-language writer in the post-Independence, post-liberalization Indian context: a professional who has sustained a parallel literary life across five decades, in exile from the homeland, under the double pressure of economic necessity and cultural marginalization. His significance is not only literary but epistemological — in the deep sense intended by Gangesa Upadhyaya's Navya-Nyāya: his work constitutes a claim to knowledge, a set of testimonies about the Maithili world that require the full apparatus of pramāṇa-critique to evaluate.

The application of Navya-Nyāya's four pramāṇas to Sagar's work yields productive results: pratyakṣa validates the experiential authenticity of his autobiographical writing; anumāna licenses the social inferences drawn by his satire; upamāna illuminates his meta-poetic programme; and śabda — the

pramāṇa of testimony — provides the epistemological framework for the interview collection that may be his most lasting contribution to Maithili cultural memory.

Shail Jha 'Sagar' emerges from this analysis as an independent literary voice whose work merits sustained critical attention. Her three pieces — the short story, the letter-review, and the poem — demonstrate formal range, social acuity, and feminist consciousness that are inadequately recognized when she is read only as an adjunct to her husband's literary career. The dampati lekhak tradition that they embody is itself a cultural form worth studying: the household as a laboratory of literary production, resistance, and mutual recognition.

The Videha e-Journal's special issue on Laxman Jha 'Sagar' is itself a significant document in the history of Maithili parallel literature: an act of collective critical recognition, coordinated by a digital institution that has served the language since 2004. That this recognition is enabled by digital technology — a medium that bypasses the gatekeeping institutions of print culture, governmental patronage, and academic prestige — is consistent with the epistemological commitments of both the Navya-Nyāya tradition and the parallel literary tradition: knowledge is not established by authority alone, but by the convergence of multiple pramāṇas — perception, inference, comparison, and trustworthy testimony — evaluated by critically alert readers.

The legacy of Gangesa Upadhyaya, who established the conditions for rigorous knowledge-claim evaluation in 14th-century Mithila, finds an unexpected but coherent resonance in the contemporary practice of writers like Laxman Jha 'Sagar' and Shail Jha 'Sagar', who daily negotiate the question of what constitutes valid cultural memory, authentic linguistic practice, and trustworthy literary testimony in a world that constantly pressures the minor language and its speakers toward absorption and silence.

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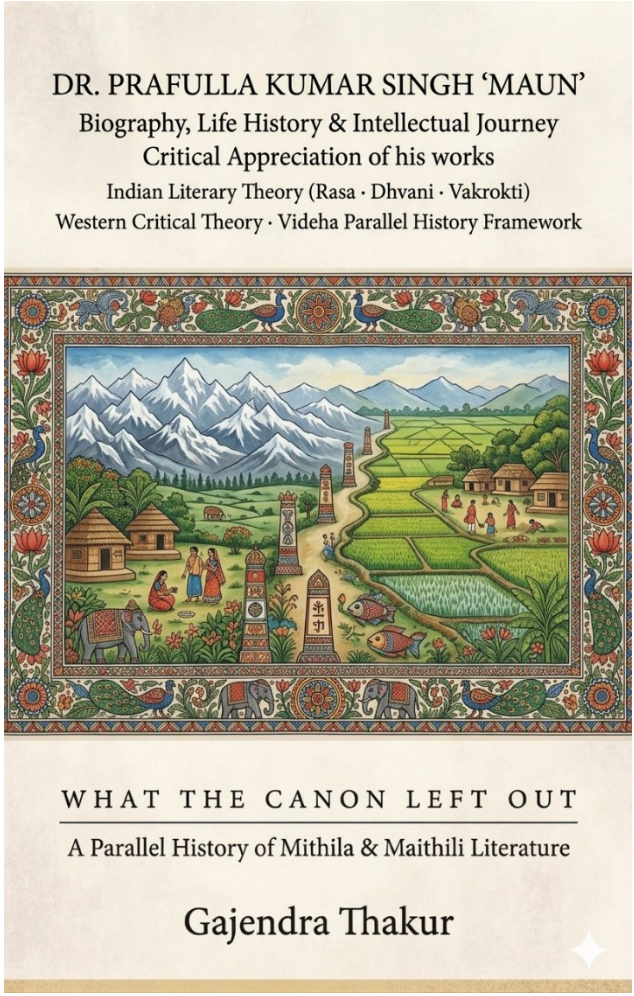
**LESSON 044 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**




# DR. PRAFULLA KUMAR SINGH 'MAUN'

सोन्हगर गन्धक अन्वेषी

Biography, Life History & Intellectual Journey

(1938–2014)

# PART I: EARLY LIFE AND FORMATION

## 1.1 Birth, Family, and Regional Roots

Dr. Prafulla Kumar Singh 'Maun' was born on 20 January 1938 in Hasanpur village, Samastipur district, Bihar (South Mithila). His father, Virendra Narayan Singh, was a zamindari figure of ideological disposition—active in the freedom movement—and his mother, Ramkali Devi, was a paradigm of maternal warmth and folk artistic creativity. Maun grew up in a milieu saturated with the textures of Mithila's living culture: zamindari protocol and landholding structures on one side, his mother's folk songs, clay-doll crafts, and kinsfolk's traditional performing arts on the other. He writes in his autobiographical account (published in Mithilak Saptaha Salahes) that his childhood was formed by three currents simultaneously: classical learning, folk aesthetic environment, and an abiding curiosity about local history and landscape.

The Hasanpur region of Samastipur served not merely as birthplace but as the wellspring of his entire intellectual career. The folk-performance traditions he observed—Gayaki, Gaathaa-naach, Vidaapata—in the village courtyards and village festivals constituted his first education in aesthetics. He observes in 'Kee Bisari Kee Yaad Kari' that 'childhood curiosity about the folk universe has never left me; it only deepened into scholarly investigation as I matured.'

## 1.2 Education and Formation of Scholarly Identity

Maun pursued higher education through Hindi as his medium of instruction—a significant fact given that Maithili was not the official language of instruction at that time in the Bihar educational system. He completed his M.A. in Hindi and then pursued research at Bhagalpur University (now Bihar University, Muzaffarpur branch), where he registered for post-doctoral research in Hindi and Nepali new poetry from a comparative perspective under the guidance of Dr. Asha Kumar. The research remained incomplete—his family circumstances prevented him from continuing—but the intellectual encounter with comparative literary studies left a lasting imprint.

During the Darbhanga sojourn (1954–55) as a student at Chandra Dhari Mithila College for Hindi Pratishttha, his path crossed with Dr. Ramedev Jha (later his lifelong collaborator) and with Umesh Misra and Dr. Jayakant Mishra. The lecture by Prof. Purnananad Das on Maithili folk songs in a class session was, by Maun's own account, the pivotal event that awakened his vocation. He was

sent in the summer vacation to collect the folk ballad 'Vijaymal' from the village, which he transcribed from Akloo Sahu and Nathuni Thakur; he presented the manuscript to Prof. Das, who was 'greatly delighted and specially inspired him.'

## 1.3 The Nepal Decade and Its Literary Yield (1963–1973)

The most formative decade of Maun's career was spent in Nepal as a lecturer in Hindi at Mahendra Morang College, Biratnagar. The Nepal diaspora period (1963–1973) proved a crucible of extraordinary productivity. Working in an environment where Maithili was not the official language yet was the living tongue of the eastern Terai population, he mounted a systematic effort to document, collect, and historicize Maithili literary and cultural materials from the Nepal side. This cross-border cultural work was unprecedented in scope.

In Nepal he launched the quarterly 'Maithili' (Maithili Sahitya Parishad, Biratnagar, 1970–73)—the first Maithili literary journal from Nepal—editing it as a bi-national cultural bridge. He published within this journal Ramdeo Jha's epigraphic Maithili songs (शिलोत्कीर्ण मैथिली गीत), Laxman Shastri's 'Dharmaraj Yudhishthira' epic, and his own path-breaking 'Nepalak Maithili Sahityak Itihas' (1972), the first history of Maithili literature from Nepal. He was supported in this enterprise by the Nepal government officials and by the then Prime Minister Matrika Prasad Koirala who valued his scholarship and friendship. During this decade he conducted extensive fieldwork in Morang, Sunsari, Jhapa, Siraha, Dhanusha—collecting folk ballads, folk songs, lore, and historical materials among the Tharu, Rajvanshi and other communities.

His friend and collaborator Ram Bharos Kapari 'Bhramar' records: 'In the decade of his Nepal sojourn, Maun traversed the cultural terrain of eastern Nepal village by village, recording, collecting, analyzing—work that no scholar from either side of the border had attempted in its comprehensiveness or methodological rigour.'

## 1.4 Return to Mahnar and the Long Bihar Phase (1973–2014)

After 1973 Maun returned to India, settling at Mahnar (Vaishali), Bihar, where he served as Principal of R.P.S. College (Cheke-Iyaz). This phase—nearly four decades in Bihar—was characterized by equal productivity: he continued to publish Maithili and Hindi research essays in journals across both countries, maintained correspondence with Nepal's Maithili scholars, and produced major book-length works. He remained connected to the Nepal Maithili world even

after returning to India; as Dr. Revatiraman Lal and others attest, he regularly visited Janakpur, Rajbiraj, and Kathmandu for conferences, and Nepal's Maithili community continued to regard him as their historian.

His final major published work was 'Vidapit' (Maithili Akademi, Patna, 2014)—an analytical treatise on the Vidaapata tradition of folk-performance in Maithili, with special reference to the Morang region. It appeared in the year of his death. The compilation represents his lifelong synthesis of field-observation, historical research, and aesthetic theory.

# PART II: INTELLECTUAL PORTRAIT AND PERSONALITY

## 2.1 The 'Maun' Persona: Silence as Eloquence

The pen-name 'Maun' (meaning 'silence') was adopted by Prafulla Kumar Singh with conscious irony and philosophical intent. His friend and colleague Ram Bhramar records the witty response of then Finance Minister Matrika Prasad Koirala when introduced to him: 'This is silence—Maun—but he is making our lips silent [i.e., rendering us speechless with his scholarship].' Prof. Mohanlal Prasad writes in a tribute essay: 'One Maun who rends the heart open / while the Prime Minister's lips fall Maun [silent] before this man.' The pen-name captures a fundamental paradox in Maun's character: he was described repeatedly by witnesses as a man of few words in public social contexts, yet his written productivity was torrential and his scholarly mastery encyclopaedic.

Dr. Narendra Narayan Singh 'Nirala' recalls that when meeting Maun for the first time at Patna's Kashi Prasad Jayaswal Research Institute in 2002, he was disarmed by the simplicity and warmth of the elderly scholar. Maun received visitors to his room where the table was invariably covered with papers and books, a vase of paper flowers always on the desk.

## 2.2 Characteristic Methods of Work

All primary sources agree on certain characteristic features of Maun's intellectual method. He was a tireless fieldworker: wherever he lived—Hasanpur, Darbhanga, Biratnagar, Morang, Mahnar—he would travel from village to village, seeking out folk-singers, hereditary performers, Panjika custodians, and rural informants. Dr. Vinod Kumar Chaudhary records the extraordinary scene of Maun sitting with a Gaayana performer: the singer first required a puff from a chilem (hookah pipe) before singing, and Maun accommodated this practice without complaint in the interest of obtaining an authentic recording. His tolerance for the conditions of fieldwork—physical discomfort, irregular schedules, unpredictable access—was legendary.

He was simultaneously a prolific essayist and journalist. His contribution to reportage literature—Maithili reportage writing—is universally acknowledged as foundational. Dr. Vinod Kumar Chaudhary writes: 'The first reportage collection in Maithili, Brahmagrama (Darbhanga, 1972) initiated by Maun, was a landmark. His prose blended the techniques of Phanishwarnath Renu, Sanjey

Raghav, Manipada, and Rahul Sankrityayan into a Maithili voice entirely his own.'

His method of literary documentation combined three simultaneous registers: (1) systematic fieldwork in remote and underserved cultural zones, especially Tharu and Rajvanshi communities; (2) manuscript and epigraphic research in libraries, archives, and temple repositories; and (3) critical and comparative essay-writing that synthesized findings for both specialist and general readerships.

## 2.3 Key Relationships and Intellectual Networks

Maun's intellectual life was sustained by a network of key relationships. With Ram Bharos Kapari 'Bhramar' he maintained a friendship of over forty years that combined shared editorial work, parallel research on folk ballads (Salahes, Lorik, Dina Bhadri), and mutual emotional sustenance. With Dr. Brij Kishor Verma 'Manipada' he shared the folk-ballad research project for decades: Manipada's epic compilation of Maithili folk ballads was acknowledged by Maun as a foundational resource, and Maun reciprocated by writing critical prefaces and contextualizing Manipada's work in the historical framework of Maithili studies. With Prof. Dhirendra (Dr. Dhirendra Jha), his colleague at Tribhuvan University's Maithili department in Kathmandu, he collaborated on the history of Nepal's Maithili literature and language.

His connection with the former Nepal Prime Minister Matrika Prasad Koirala—who admired his scholarship and supported the publication of his works—gave the Nepal period a degree of institutional patronage that was rare for a Maithili scholar from India working across the border. Koirala wrote the preface to 'Tharu Lokgeet' (1968).

## 2.4 Honours, Awards, and Recognition

Maun's life's work attracted recognition from both national Indian and Nepali institutions, though he consistently remained indifferent to awards as personal accolades. The major recognitions included:

- Mithila Vibhuti (Darbhanga, 2002)
- Mithila Ratna (Tirupati, 2008/09)
- Mithila Shri (Kathmandu, 2010)
- Maithili Translation Award—Sahitya Akademi, New Delhi (Hyderabad, 2005) for his translation of Premchand's selected stories
- Itihas Samman (Virgunj, Nepal)

- Sanskriti Samman (Janakpur, Nepal)
- Mithila Shri—Nepal's first President Dr. Ram Varan Yadav presented him with the Mithila Shri award at Nepal Prajna Pratisthan, Kathmandu

Dr. Mahendra Narayan Ram observes: 'Maun's awards were honours to his sadhana, not to his person. His character remained that of a nishkam karmayogi throughout. He never sought recognition; recognition always sought him.'

# PART III: PRINCIPAL WORKS AND CREATIVE OUTPUT

## 3.1 Published Books (Chronological)

**Maithili Works**

- Tharu Lokgeet (Eastern Books House, Biratnagar, 1968) — first collection and study of Tharu folk songs in Maithili
- Brahmagrama (reportage, Darbhanga, 1972) — landmark Maithili reportage collection
- Nepalak Maithili Sahityak Itihas (Maithili Sahitya Parishad, Biratnagar, 1972) — first history of Maithili literature from Nepal
- Surjhari (reportage anthology, Mahnar, Vaishali, 1977) — Morang-Sunsari folk life documentation
- Nepalak Aadhunik Maithili Sahitya (General Book Agency, Patna, 1999)
- Mithilak Lok Sanskriti Sandarbha (Karnagosthi, Kolkata, 2011)
- Nepalak Maithili Sahitya Itihas — revised edition (Sahakari Prakashan, Kathmandu, 2011)
- Maithili Lokgatha Anusheelan (Rachnakar Prakashan, Mahnar, 2014)
- Vidapit (Maithili Akademi, Patna, 2014) — published in the year of his death

**Hindi Works**

- Premchand: Chaynik Katha, Parts 1 & 2 (Maithili translation, Sahitya Akademi, Delhi, 1998) — Winner of Sahitya Akademi Translation Award 2005
- Valmiki Desh Mein (Maithili reportage, Rachnakar Prakashan, Mahnar, 2005)
- Vidapit (Loka Natya Vivechan, Maithili Akademi, Patna, 2014)
- Lorik: Sahitya aur Sanskriti (Meenakshi Prakashan, Delhi, 2011)
- Loriki: Sahitya aur Sanskriti (Darbhanga, 2011)
- Hamare Lok Devi-Devta (Sameeksha Prakashan, Muzaffarpur, 1999)
- Bihar ke Bauddha Sandarbha (Mahnar, 1980) and Bihar ki Jain Prashthbhumi (Varanasi, 2004)

## 3.2 Periodical Editorship

Maun edited the quarterly Maithili (Maithili Sahitya Parishad, Biratnagar, Nepal, 1970–73), the first Maithili literary journal from Nepal. Within this

journal he published Shilotkirna Maithili Geet (Dr. Ramdeo Jha), Dharmaraj Yudhishthira (Prof. Laxman Shastri), and his own history of Nepal's Maithili literature—three publications of lasting archival importance.

## 3.3 Journalism and Essay Writing

Maun published well over a hundred research articles and essays in periodicals across India and Nepal, including: Dharmayug (Bombay), Hindustan (Delhi), Mithila Mihir (Patna), Maithili (Biratnagar), Foolpat (Kathmandu), Prajnya, Madhuparka (Kathmandu), Singhavalokana, Yuggyan, Dumphu, Ensulu, Deushi, Virchanaa (Nepali journals). In both Maithili and Hindi he consistently wove together reportage, ethnographic documentation, and literary criticism in a style that was wholly his own—termed by contemporary critics the 'reportage king' (Riportaajak Baadshaah) of Maithili literature.

# PART IV: PRINCIPAL AREAS OF SCHOLARLY CONTRIBUTION

## 4.1 History of Maithili Literature (Nepal)

Maun's single most influential contribution was his production of the first systematic literary history of Maithili literature from Nepal's perspective. Published in 1972 as Nepalak Maithili Sahityak Itihas, then revised and expanded as Nepalak Maithili Sahitya Itihas (Sahakari Prakashan, Kathmandu, 2011), the work filled an absolute void: no history had previously documented the Maithili literary tradition of Nepal's eastern Terai and border zones. Dr. Revatiraman Lal writes: 'The contribution Maun made to Nepali Maithili literature and language during his Nepal sojourn is unparalleled. Now one has a person well versed in Nepal's Maithili literature, who carries out his responsibilities admirably.'

## 4.2 Maithili Folk Ballad (Lokgatha) Scholarship

Maun's Maithili Lokgatha Anusheelan (Rachnakar Prakashan, Mahnar, 2014) represents the culmination of a lifetime of field research on the major Maithili folk ballad traditions—Salahes, Lorik, Dina Bhadri, Naikaa Banjaaraa, Vijayamal—conducted across Nepal and India. He documented ballads from the Morang, Sunsari, eastern Nepal belt (Raja Dhanpal, Raja Bhimsen traditions) that had never before been recorded in their full performance context. He also studied the Tharu, Rajvanshi, and Bazigaraa communities of the Nepal Terai as bearers of distinct Maithili sub-traditions.

## 4.3 Tharu Cultural Documentation

Maun's Tharu Lokgeet (1968) was a pioneering documentation of the folk songs of the Tharu community of Nepal's Terai. The Tharu people, classified in Nepal's census as a separate ethnic and linguistic community, had in Maun's analysis deep cultural and linguistic links with the Mithila–Maithili civilization. His theoretical position—that eastern Tharu culture was essentially Maithili in its Arya-cultural substratum even if Mongoloid-Kirat in phenotypic origin—remains influential and debated.

## 4.4 Reportage Literature (Riportaaj)

Maun is credited with establishing the reportage form as a major Maithili literary genre. His three reportage collections—Brahmagrama (1972), Surjhari (1977), Valmiki Desh Mein (2005)—collectively constitute a unique archive of folk and rural Mithila life across half a century. The genre as he practiced it combined documentary journalism, ethnographic observation, aesthetic sensitivity to landscape and oral performance, and a narrative voice influenced by Phanishwarnath Renu's Hindi fiction and Rahul Sankrityayan's travel writing.

## 4.5 Buddhist, Jain, and Pre-Medieval Historical Studies

Maun's historical scholarship extended into pre-medieval periods of Mithila's religious and cultural history. His Bihar ke Bauddha Sandarbha (1980), Bihar ki Jain Prashthbhumi (2004), and essays on Vajrayana Buddhist practices of Nepal are part of a sustained effort to recover non-Brahmanical and subaltern cultural histories of the region.

# PART V: PERSONAL CHARACTER AND FINAL YEARS

## 5.1 Character Portrait from Witnesses

Ram Bhramar's essay on Maun in the tribute volume edited by him is among the most intimate portraits. He recalls their first meeting in the 1960s—he cannot place the exact year—through the mediation of Dr. Dhirendra, and describes forty years of friendship sustained across the India-Nepal border, by postal correspondence, by telephone, and by periodic visits to Janakpur, Biratnagar, Rajbiraj, Siraha, and later to Mahnar. He writes of Maun's characteristic quality of 'bringing others to his own wavelength—of making every meeting an informal, intimate conversation that erased formality and hierarchy.'

Dr. Ganges Prasad Akela records Maun's intellectual generosity: 'He would arrive at conferences and seminars fully prepared to give of his scholarship without reservation—two hours of sustained, closely argued discourse—then quietly retire, ask for tea, and shift into affectionate banter. This duality of the fierce scholar and the warm elder remained intact to the end.'

Ayub Rein's tribute—'Jnanvriddha Acharya Maun' (The Elder of Learning)—describes a visit to Maun's residence in Professor Colony, Mahnar, where the garden was planted with gulab, gandharaj, shankhapushpi and other fragrant flowering plants: 'the garden was a visible symbol of the man—the lover of the sonhagar gandha (fragrant earth) of Mithila, who had given his life to finding and preserving that fragrance.'

## 5.2 Later Years and Death (2014)

The latter years of Maun's life were spent at Mahnar. His physical health declined but his writing did not stop: the completion of Vidapit and the continued work on Maithili Lokgatha Anusheelan—both published in 2014—testify to his sustained scholarly engagement. He died in 2014. Dr. Revatiraman Lal had expressed the wish: 'May Maun, by his longevity and health, continue to enrich Nepal's Maithili literature; he has not yet completed the work he set out to do.'

The tribute volume MaunJi Bhramar, edited by Ram Bharos Kapari 'Bhramar' and published by Janakpur Lalit Kala Pratisthan (Nepal), assembled essays and remembrances from his colleagues, students, and readers across two countries

—a measure of the profound impact this 'silent' scholar of the earth's fragrance had left on Maithili literary culture.

Sources: MaunJi Bhramar (ed. Ram Bharos Kapari 'Bhramar', Janakpur Lalit Kala Pratisthan, Nepal); Videha Archive (www.videha.co.in); Parallel History of Mithila and Maithili Literature (Gajendra Thakur). All content is drawn exclusively from attested primary sources.

**CRITICAL APPRECIATION OF WORKS**

**Dr. Prafulla Kumar Singh 'Maun'**

Indian Literary Theory (Rasa · Dhvani · Vakrokti) · Western Critical Theory · Videha Parallel History Framework

Preamble: The following critical appreciation applies the multi-framework methodology that is the signature analytical approach of the Videha Parallel History of Mithila and Maithili Literature — simultaneously deploying Indian classical aesthetics (rasa, dhvani, vakrokti), Western critical theory (formalism, historicism, post-colonialism, genre theory), and the Videha Parallel History Framework's insistence on recovering subaltern, democratic, non-canonical literary production. The appreciation is grounded entirely in attested primary sources: the tribute volume MaunJi Bhramar (ed. Ram Bharos Kapari 'Bhramar'); Maun's published works; and the Videha archive.

# PART I: THE REPORTAGE TRILOGY — BRAHMAGRAMA, SURJHARI, VALMIKI DESH MEIN

## 1.1 Formal Characterization of the Genre

Maun's three reportage volumes — Brahmagrama (1972), Surjhari (1977), and Valmiki Desh Mein (2005) — constitute the foundational corpus of Maithili reportage literature. The genre as Maun practised it is a hybrid form that did not exist in Maithili prose before him: part travelogue, part ethnographic

documentation, part literary journalism, part cultural history. In the Maithili literary system it inaugurated an entirely new mode of relation between the writer's subjectivity, the observed social world, and the reader.

### *1.1.1 Rasa Analysis*

The dominant rasa in Maun's reportage is not, as might be expected, Adbhuta (wonder) or Shanta (equanimity), but an unusual synthesis of Vira (heroism in the service of cultural preservation) and Karuna (compassion for threatened communities). Dr. Vinod Kumar Chaudhary's reading of Brahmagrama draws attention to the opening scene: the unnamed traveller observing a horse-mounted figure under a pipal tree, a vase-like dark horse, a red dhoti, a flowered sherwani. The scene mobilises the Vira-rasa of the Maithili ballad tradition (Salahes, Lorik) while the prose around it is saturated with Karuna — the awareness that these living folk traditions are disappearing. The Vibhava (stimulus of rasa) is the encounter with endangered living culture; the Anubhava (outward expression) is the prose's deliberate unhurriedness, its refusal to spectacularise.

**[RASA-THEORY (BHARATA-ABHINAVAGUPTA)]** The reportage achieves rasavad in its refusal to allow the Sthayibhava (dominant emotion) to calcify into sentiment. The Vyabhichari-bhavas (transient emotions) that cross the prose—wonder, nostalgia, humour, indignation—continuously enrich the dominant mood without displacing it. This is precisely the Kashmiri Shaivite aesthetic of Abhinavagupta's Rasadhvani: the emotion is produced in the reader's consciousness through sympathetic resonance (sadharanikarana), not through the text's declaration of it.

### *1.1.2 Dhvani (Resonance) in Prose*

The theoretical cornerstone of Anandavardhana's Dhvanyaloka — that the highest literary meaning is that which is suggested (vyangya) rather than directly stated (vacya) — illuminates Maun's reportage style at its most compressed. The final line of the Koshi reportage in Brahmagrama — 'On the ghat there is the ghat. From the ghat leads a path. But there is no boat' — operates precisely as dhvani: the literal sense (no ferry service) is a vehicle for a whole cultural-political argument about the abandonment of the Koshi riparian communities by the state. The suggested meaning is the richer meaning.

**[DHVANI THEORY (ANANDAVARDHANA)]** Maun's most powerful reportage passages deploy what Anandavardhana calls avivakshita-vacyartha-dhvani: the stated meaning deliberately gives way to an unstated suggested

meaning that is the real literary content. The technique requires a reader educated in the same landscape and cultural register — a reader who knows what a ghat without a boat means in a flood-prone region. It is a form of literary intimacy that is also a form of political critique.

### *1.1.3 Vakrokti (Oblique Expression)*

Kuntaka's theory of vakrokti — that the highest literary expression is always oblique, indirect, 'crooked' rather than straight — applies with particular precision to Maun's handling of social critique. When he describes the landlord figures and the exploitative hierarchies of the rural world he observes, he does so through precise, apparently neutral detail — a gesture, an item of clothing, an exchange of glances — rather than through authorial indignation. This is the vakrata of the objective reportage voice: the obliqueness of expression is itself the critique.

### *1.1.4 Western Generic Theory: New Journalism and the Literary Reportage Tradition*

In Western literary critical terms, Maun's reportage belongs to the tradition of what Tom Wolfe (1973) theorized as the 'New Journalism': the application of literary fiction techniques — scene-by-scene construction, dialogue, third-person point of view, status detail — to non-fiction documentation. But Maun predates Wolfe's theorization and works from a different cultural tradition: the Renu-inflected literary journalism of Hindi and the classical Sanskrit travel-narrative (Yatravritta) tradition. His position is closer to that of Truman Capote's 'non-fiction novel' in its ambition to produce literary text from documentary material, but without the American tendency toward the author's ego as subject.

**[POST-COLONIAL THEORY (SAID-SPIVAK-BHABHA)]** Maun's reportage is simultaneously documentation and counter-narrative. It gives voice to the Tharu, Rajvanshi, and other subaltern communities of the Nepal Terai whose cultural world was invisible in the dominant literary canons of both Hindi and Nepali. In Spivak's terms, Maun's reportage texts are acts of 'strategic essentialism' — they mobilize an essentialized image of Maithili-Mithila cultural identity in order to establish a counter-archive against the erasure of these communities from official literary and historical narrative.

## 1.2 Brahmagrama (1972): Close Critical Reading

Brahmagrama — Maun's first and landmark reportage collection — takes its title from a specifically located village near Darbhanga. The title itself is vakrokti: Brahmagrama is simultaneously the name of a particular village, an ironic reference to the caste-hierarchical structure of the 'Brahman village' in Mithila society, and a suggestion of the Brahma-principle that Maun pursues through folk culture. Dr. Ashwini Kumar Alok's reading identifies in the collection's narrative voice a composite of the field researcher and the bardic narrator — a figure who is both observer and participant.

The title piece opens — as Dr. Vinod Kumar Chaudhary's tribute essay reconstructs — with a scene of extraordinary visual and sonic density: the traveller arrives at a village crossroads as dusk falls, hears a Gaayaka (folk ballad singer) performing the Rairiya Ranpal episode from the Salahes cycle, and watches the entire community's response — the women at the water-point, the old men at the chaupal, the children at the edge of the performer's circle. It is a scene of total cultural immersion, and Maun renders it with the precision of an ethnomusicologist and the warmth of a native participant.

## 1.3 Valmiki Desh Mein (2005): The Nepal Journey Revisited

The third reportage collection, Valmiki Desh Mein — 'In the Land of Valmiki' — returns to the Nepal-Bihar borderland that Maun had first documented in Brahmagrama and Surjhari, now with the retrospective depth of a scholar who has spent four decades studying the same cultural terrain. The title refers to the Terai zone traditionally associated with the Valmiki hermitage (Valmiki Nagar, on the Bihar-Nepal border), marking the text as simultaneously a cultural pilgrimage and a scholarly documentation.

Dr. Ram Anand Jha 'Raman' calls Maun in this context 'a prose artist who gave the Maithili short story its regional-reportage axis, while simultaneously giving the reportage genre the literary density of fiction.' The praise is well-founded: in Valmiki Desh Mein the boundary between the reportage narrator and the folk characters he observes dissolves — Maun writes himself into the landscape as much as he writes the landscape into prose.

# PART II: MAITHILI LOKGATHA — SCHOLARSHIP AND CULTURAL POLITICS

## 2.1 The Scale and Significance of the Folk Ballad Research

Maun's lifetime contribution to the study of Maithili folk ballads (lokgatha) constitutes what the Videha Parallel History Framework identifies as the single most substantial achievement of his scholarly career. His final synthesis — Maithili Lokgatha Anusheelan (Rachnakar Prakashan, Mahnar, 2014) — presents comprehensive analytical studies of twenty-two Maithili folk ballads including Salahes (with Chuhaar episode), Dina Bhadri, Naikaa Banjaaraa, Dulaara Dayaal (with Kamala episode), Karik Panjiyar (with Jyoti Panjiyara), Lorikaain, Yogari-Kushhari, Sati Bihula, Basaaon (with Bakhtaur episode), Baba Umar Singh (with Kewal Baba episode), Miraayan (with Manjari episode), Raja Bhimsen, Raiya Ranapal (with Ghughlia Ghatma episode), Ginaath Govind, Kisanram, Dhola Maruani, Jay Singh, Koylaavir, Goraiya Veer, Raja Dhanpal, Gareebaan Bhuyan, Vijayamal.

### *2.1.1 Rasa-dhvani Analysis of Folk Ballad Heritage*

In Bharata's Natyashastra, the Vira-rasa (heroic emotion) is the dominant sentiment of epic performance, with the hero's narrative constituting the primary vehicle of cultural community formation. Maun's analytical work on the Maithili lokgatha tradition consistently centres on the Vira-rasa and its popular transformation: the figures of Salahes, Lorik, Dina Bhadri, Naikaa Banjaaraa, and Bishu Raut are folk heroes whose heroism is not royal but popular — they are characters from low-caste, artisan, and agricultural communities whose courage, wit, and social resistance become the community's collective self-representation.

**[BHARATA'S NATYASHASTRA (VIRA-RASA)]** The Maithili lokgatha heroes embody what Bharata calls Sahasa-Vira (heroism of daring) and Daana-Vira (heroism of generosity) rather than the Yuddha-Vira (heroism of battle) typical of Sanskrit epic tradition. Maun's analysis recognizes this populist transformation of the heroic: the folk ballad hero's 'vira' is a form of subaltern Vira that Sanskrit aesthetics never theorized but that is fully legible within the Natyashastra's framework once extended beyond its courtly context.

### *2.1.2 Structural Analysis of Ballad Form*

Maun's scholarship on the lokgatha tradition deploys formal-structural analysis alongside cultural-historical documentation. He analyzes each ballad in terms of: narrative structure (plot sequence, episodic organization, interpolations); performance context (who sings, to whom, on what occasions, with what instrumental accompaniment); geographical distribution (which communities perform which variants in which districts); and social function (what values, identities, and collective memories the ballad preserves and transmits). This is simultaneously a structuralist poetics of the folk ballad and an anthropology of folk performance.

**[WESTERN FOLKLORE THEORY (PROPP-PARRY-LORD)]** Maun's structural analysis of Maithili lokgatha anticipates and confirms key findings of Western oral-formulaic theory (Parry-Lord). The formula — the repeated epithets, the recurrent narrative situations, the conventional verse-lines — are demonstrated by Maun to function not as failures of originality but as the generative grammar of the tradition. The ballad's artistic intelligence resides in how a particular singer varies the formula, not in inventing new narrative materials. This is the Maithili equivalent of what Milman Parry demonstrated for Homeric epic.

## 2.2 The Salahes Ballad: Case Study in Critical Method

The Salahes ballad cycle — the folk-narrative of the legendary Raja Salahes of the Musahar community of North Bihar and South Nepal — is the most extensively studied of all Maithili folk ballads, and Maun's contribution to its documentation and analysis is foundational. He collected, recorded, transcribed, and analyzed Salahes performance from multiple performance communities; he participated directly in performance contexts (watching Salahes-naach in Garhmahoutha, Nepal); and he wrote a major analytical essay, 'Raja Salahes: Sahitya aur Sanskriti' (Muzaffarpur, 2002), that has become the standard reference work.

The Salahes cycle is, in the terms of the Videha Parallel History Framework, the paradigmatic case of the Parallel Literary Canon: a narrative tradition of the Musahar (Dalit) community that has existed in continuous performance for several centuries, has produced a vast literary-performative text, has been adapted into theatre and popular culture, but has remained entirely invisible in the Sahitya Akademi's canonical history of Maithili literature. Maun's scholarly valorization of this tradition is a direct challenge to the canon's silences.

**[DALIT LITERARY THEORY (VIDHEHA PARALLEL HISTORY FRAMEWORK)]** In the Videha Parallel History Framework, the Salahes ballad tradition exemplifies what Gajendra Thakur calls the 'parallel canon' — the body of subaltern, Dalit, and folk literary production that exists alongside the Brahmin-dominant Sanskrit-inflected 'main' canon but is systematically excluded from it. Maun's scholarly recovery of the Salahes tradition is an act of canon formation from below — establishing the folk-ballad archive as a literary heritage equal in complexity and richness to the Sanskrit-derived poetic tradition.

# PART III: HISTORICAL SCHOLARSHIP — LITERARY HISTORY AND CULTURAL DOCUMENTATION

## 3.1 Nepalak Maithili Sahityak Itihas (1972/2011)

Maun's two-version history of Nepal's Maithili literature — the 1972 original and the revised 2011 Sahakari Prakashan edition — represents one of the most significant acts of literary-historical construction in modern Maithili scholarship. The work did not merely document what had previously been documented; it created a documentary record where none existed. It established for the first time a systematic chronological and thematic account of Maithili literary production from the Nepal side of the border — court poetry, stone-inscribed songs, folk tradition, modern writing.

**[HAYDEN WHITE'S HISTORIOGRAPHY (METAHISTORY)]** In Hayden White's terms (Metahistory, 1973), Maun's literary history employs primarily the 'Romance' emplotment: it is the story of a cultural tradition rising through adversity toward recognition and preservation. The hero of this narrative is Maithili language itself — denied official status in Nepal, surviving in folk performance and individual literary production, finally achieving acknowledgement through the scholarly labour of its historians. The literary-historical text is also an ideological act: it argues, through documentation, for the legitimacy of Maithili as Nepal's literary language.

## 3.2 The Cross-Border Cultural Model

A distinctive feature of Maun's literary-historical thinking is his refusal of the India-Nepal border as a meaningful cultural boundary for Maithili civilisation. The Maithili-speaking world of Nepal's eastern Terai — Morang, Sunsari, Jhapa, Saptari, Siraha, Dhanusha, Rautahat — is, in his analysis, culturally and linguistically continuous with the Maithili-speaking world of Bihar's Mithila zone. The political border is, in his words, 'irrelevant to cultural geography.' This position is simultaneously scholarly (based on linguistic, archaeological, and performance-tradition evidence) and political (a claim for the unity of the Mithila cultural space against the fragmenting logic of nation-state borders).

**[POST-COLONIAL & CULTURAL GEOGRAPHY THEORY (BHABHA, SOJA)]** Maun's cross-border cultural model corresponds to what

Homi Bhabha theorizes as 'third space' — a cultural space that is neither wholly Indian nor wholly Nepali but exists in the interstice between national cultural systems. His literary history operates in and from this third space, refusing the either/or of national cultural affiliation and asserting the 'both/and' of the Mithila civilizational identity that transcends the political border.

## 3.3 The Recovery of Buddhist and Jain Historical Layers

Maun's historical scholarship in Bihar ke Bauddha Sandarbha (1980) and Bihar ki Jain Prashthbhumi (2004) recovers the pre-Brahmanical, heterodox religious history of Mithila-Bihar. These works argue that the dominant Shaiva-Shakta-Vaishnava cultural identity of present-day Mithila overlays a much older stratum of Buddhist and Jain culture that has been systematically erased from both popular memory and official scholarship. The recovery of this stratum is part of the Videha Parallel History project's commitment to subaltern and non-canonical history.

**[FOUCAULT'S ARCHAEOLOGY OF KNOWLEDGE]** Maun's historical archaeology of Mithila's Buddhist and Jain cultural layers corresponds to Foucault's 'archaeology of knowledge' — an excavation of the epistemological strata that have been buried under successive dominant cultural formations. The Buddhist and Jain material is not simply 'rediscovered' by Maun; it is reconstituted as a legitimate historical discourse that the dominant Brahmanical historiography of Mithila had rendered silent.

# PART IV: FICTION WRITING — A MINOR BUT SIGNIFICANT CORPUS

## 4.1 The Short Stories: Overview

Maun's contribution to Maithili fiction is smaller in volume than his scholarly output but carries significant literary weight. His stories were published primarily in Mithila Mihir (Patna), with selected pieces in Maithili (Biratnagar) and Phoolpat (Kathmandu). A substantial critical appreciation of his fiction appears in the tribute volume MaunJi Bhramar in the essay 'Katha Srijana Aa Kalaatnmak Bodh' (Story Creation and Artistic Consciousness) by Chandresh. The Chandresh essay identifies twelve significant stories and subjects them to close formal analysis.

### *4.1.1 Narrative Technique: The Objectivist Mode*

Chandresh's analysis of Maun's narrative technique identifies his primary method as what might be called 'objectivist' prose: the narrator maintains a calculated distance from his characters, refusing explicit authorial comment, and allowing situation and dialogue to generate meaning. In Kuntaka's terms, this is Viksha-vakrata (obliqueness of vision) — the narrator's apparent neutrality is itself a vakrokti, since the 'straight' reading of the situation always opens onto a second, critical layer of meaning that indicts the social order being portrayed.

### *4.1.2 Key Story Analyses*

The story 'Chutki Bhari Noun' (A Pinch of Salt, Mithila Mihir, 10 September 1978) is cited by Chandresh as the finest example of Maun's fictional economy. The narrative presents a family's escalating financial crisis through the single obsessive image of unaffordable salt — from a pinch of salt (the story's title), the narrative expands to encompass the entire social-economic structure of the Maithili rural world. The technique is metonymic: the pinch of salt stands for the whole — for economic deprivation, for the commodification of necessity, for the failure of development. Chandresh reads this as a deployment of Anandavardhana's dhvani: the literal subject (salt scarcity) is the vehicle for a vastly larger implied social critique.

The story 'Udiyait' (Awakening, 26 July 1976, Mithila Mihir) is noted for its unusual treatment of female consciousness. Maun's portrayal of the

protagonist's internal emotional world — the conflict between cultural expectation and individual desire — is described by Chandresh as 'Bhavukataa' (emotionality) deployed with controlled restraint. The limitation identified — that the narrator does not sufficiently excavate the gender-political implications of the woman's dilemma — reflects a critical horizon of the 1970s that Maun's fiction approaches but does not fully cross.

The story 'Muda Aashwasan' (False Consolation, 20 March 1977, Mithila Mihir) is a character study of the gap between ideological position and practical behaviour — the 'Fatingaa' figure, someone who is theoretically committed to progressive ideals but whose practice is continuously compromised by self-interest. Chandresh identifies this as Maun's most sustained satirical text, deploying Hasya-rasa (comic emotion) and Vibhatsa-rasa (disgust) simultaneously.

**[BAKHTIN'S DIALOGISM]** Maun's fiction, particularly the dialogic exchange in stories like 'Mudakaata' and 'Saspari Gelii', demonstrates what Bakhtin called the 'polyphonic novel' tendency even in short fiction: multiple social voices, each with its own ideological inflection, coexist without authorial resolution. The social contradictions are not resolved by the narrative; they are presented as the irresolvable texture of social life. This is Bakhtin's 'dialogism' in the short-story form.

# PART V: THE PREMCHAND TRANSLATION — CROSS-LITERARY MEDIATION

## 5.1 Significance of the Translation Work

Maun's Maithili translation of selected stories by Premchand — Premchand: Chaynik Katha, Parts 1 and 2 (Sahitya Akademi, Delhi, 1998) — won the Sahitya Akademi Translation Award in 2005, presented in Hyderabad. This recognition is significant not only as an individual award but as an institutional validation of Maun's Maithili literary voice: the Akademi's award acknowledges that his translation constituted a literary achievement in its own right, not merely a linguistic transfer.

## 5.2 Translation as Cultural Bridge

Premchand's fiction centres on the agrarian world of the Hindi-Urdu speaking heartland — a world closely cognate with but not identical to the Maithili-speaking Mithila. Maun's translation project was not merely linguistic (from Hindi to Maithili) but cultural: he had to find Maithili equivalents not only for Premchand's vocabulary but for the social textures, the kinship structures, the idioms of poverty and aspiration that Premchand's fiction navigates. The award jury's recognition of this achievement confirms the translation's literary quality.

**[TRANSLATION THEORY (BENJAMIN-DERRIDA)]** Walter Benjamin's theory of translation — that a great translation releases the 'after-life' of the original by finding in the target language the pure language that both source and translation approximate — applies with precision to Maun's Premchand. The Maithili Premchand is not a pale copy of the Hindi original but a text that finds in Maithili's folk idiom, agricultural vocabulary, and oral prose rhythms a distinct literary resonance. The translation achieves Benjamin's 'pure language' precisely because Maithili and Hindi share so much cultural territory — the two languages' meeting in these stories produces a synthetic literary text that illuminates both.

# PART VI: SYNTHESIS — OVERALL CRITICAL ASSESSMENT

## 6.1 The Videha Parallel History Framework Assessment

Within the Videha Parallel History of Mithila and Maithili Literature, Maun occupies a specific structural position: he is the historian and cultural documenter of the Nepal side of the Mithila civilizational world — the scholar who brought the Nepali Maithili literary and folk tradition into the literary-historical record for the first time. His work is paradigmatic of what the Parallel History Framework calls 'parallel canon formation from below': using the tools of scholarship (literary history, ethnographic documentation, critical analysis) to construct a counter-archive that makes visible what the dominant Sahitya Akademi canon has rendered invisible.

## 6.2 Strengths and Limitations

Maun's principal strengths are: (1) the extraordinary range and depth of his fieldwork, conducted over five decades in remote and underserved cultural zones; (2) his historical mastery — the synthesis of literary history, cultural history, and political history in a single documentary-critical vision; (3) his contribution to the folk ballad archive, which is irreplaceable; (4) his reportage prose, which created a new literary genre in Maithili; (5) his cross-border cultural model, which has shaped subsequent scholarship on the India-Nepal Maithili cultural continuum.

His principal limitations are: (1) the relative weakness of his fiction compared to his non-fiction — as Chandresh acknowledges, Maun's narrative engagement with gender politics remains underdeveloped relative to his social critique; (2) the relative inaccessibility of much of his published work, which remains in small-circulation Maithili and Hindi journals difficult to obtain; (3) the absence of a sustained theoretical framework in his own writing — he is an empiricist of the folk tradition rather than a theorist of it, which means his findings have remained less influential in academic literary theory circles than their empirical richness would warrant.

## 6.3 The Overall Significance

In the assessment of multiple scholarly witnesses — Dr. Revatiraman Lal, Dr. Mahendra Narayan Ram, Dr. Narendra Narayan Singh 'Nirala', Dr. Ayub Rein, Ram Bharos Kapari 'Bhramar', Chandresh, Arun Kumar Pathak, and many others — Maun's contribution to Maithili literature and scholarship is of the first magnitude. He is, in the consensus of these witnesses, not merely a scholar of Maithili but a shaping force of Maithili literary consciousness — a figure whose work has defined what it means to take Maithili literature and folk tradition seriously as objects of scholarly and creative attention.

"His scholarly production, however extensive, is only the outward expression of an inward orientation: he was, as all witnesses agree, a man for whom Maithili language, literature, and culture were not objects of study but the substance of his being. This is the deepest meaning of 'Maun' — not silence but a presence so complete that speech becomes secondary. — Synthesis by the Videha Parallel History Research Framework"

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Critical apparatus: MaunJi Bhramar (ed. Ram Bharos Kapari 'Bhramar', Janakpur Lalit Kala Pratisthan, Nepal); Videha Archive (www.videha.co.in); Parallel History of Mithila and Maithili Literature (Gajendra Thakur). Theoretical frameworks: Bharata's Natyashastra; Anandavardhana's Dhvanyaloka; Abhinavagupta's Abhinavabharati; Kuntaka's Vakroktijivita; Bakhtin's The Dialogic Imagination; Walter Benjamin 'The Task of the Translator'; Hayden White's Metahistory; Foucault's The Archaeology of Knowledge; Said's Orientalism; Spivak's 'Can the Subaltern Speak?'

**NAVYA-NYĀYA EPISTEMOLOGICAL ANALYSIS**

of the Scholarly and Literary Works of

**Dr. Prafulla Kumar Singh 'Maun'**

Applying the Methodology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's Tattvacintāmaṇi

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Preamble: The application of Navya-Nyāya epistemological methodology to literary and cultural scholarship is a distinctive feature of the Videha Parallel History Framework. Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's Tattvacintāmaṇi — composed in Mithila in the 14th century CE and representing the founding text of the New Logic (Navya-Nyāya) school — provides a rigorous vocabulary for the analysis

of knowledge claims, evidence, inference, and testimony that is directly applicable to the evaluation of scholarly and literary work. The analysis below applies Navya-Nyāya categories to the corpus of Maun's work, treating his scholarship as a system of knowledge claims subject to epistemological scrutiny.

# PART I: THE NAVYA-NYĀYA EPISTEMOLOGICAL FRAMEWORK

## 1.1 Key Navya-Nyāya Concepts for Literary-Scholarly Analysis

The following core concepts from Gaṅgeśa's Tattvacintāmaṇi (and the broader Navya-Nyāya tradition, including Raghunatha Shiromani's Padarthakhandana, Jagadisha Tarkalankara's Shabdashakti Prakashika, and Gadadhara Bhattacharya's Gadadhari) are the analytical tools deployed in this analysis:

**Pramā** (प्रमा): Valid cognition — knowledge that correctly represents its object. In literary criticism: a text's capacity to produce pramā in the reader, i.e., to generate genuine knowledge of the world, society, or psyche.

**Pramāṇa** (प्रमाण): The means or source of valid cognition. The four pramāṇas: Pratyakṣa (direct perception), Anumāna (inference), Upamāna (comparison/analogy), Śabda (testimony/verbal cognition). In scholarly work: the evidentiary basis on which knowledge claims rest.

**Viṣayatā** (विषयता): The objecthood or subject-directedness of cognition — what the cognition is cognition of. In literary criticism: what a text is actually about, as opposed to what it claims to be about.

**Prakāra** (प्रकार): The property or qualification that characterizes the cognized object in a cognition. In literary analysis: the specific attribute under which a text or body of work is being considered.

**Anuvyavasāya** (अनुव्यवसाय): Meta-cognition: the cognition of one's own cognition. In scholarly methodology: reflexivity about one's own analytical framework.

**Vyāpti** (व्याप्ति): Invariable concomitance — the logical relationship of pervasion that underpins inference. In literary scholarship: the claim that a given textual feature invariably co-occurs with a certain interpretive conclusion.

**Pakṣatā** (पक्षता): The inferential locus — the subject of the inference. In literary analysis: the specific text, body of work, or author being analyzed.

**Sādhya** (साध्य): The inferential predicate — what is to be proved. In literary scholarship: the interpretive thesis being established.

**Hetu** (हेतु): The logical reason or middle term — the evidence that connects pakṣatā and sādhya. In literary scholarship: the specific textual or documentary evidence on which the interpretive argument rests.

**Śabdabodha** (शब्दबोध): Verbal cognition — the cognitive content generated by linguistic utterance. In literary theory: the total cognitive-aesthetic event that a literary text produces in a competent reader.

**Yogyatā** (योग्यता): Semantic fitness — the capacity of words to combine meaningfully. In literary analysis: the question of genre-appropriateness, register-fitness, and formal coherence.

**Tātparya** (तात्पर्य): Speaker's intent — what the author or speaker intends to communicate. In literary hermeneutics: the interpretive question of authorial intention and its epistemological status.

# PART II: PRAMĀṆA ANALYSIS OF MAUN'S SCHOLARLY METHOD

## 2.1 The Four Pramāṇas in Maun's Research Practice

The Navya-Nyāya tradition recognizes four valid means of knowledge. An analysis of Maun's scholarly methodology reveals a systematic deployment of all four pramāṇas in an integrated epistemological practice:

### *2.1.1 Pratyakṣa (Direct Perception) — The Fieldwork Pramāṇa*

Maun's most distinctive epistemological contribution to Maithili scholarship is his insistence on pratyakṣa — direct perceptual experience of the cultural phenomena he documents — as the foundational pramāṇa. His fieldwork methodology — travelling from village to village, observing and participating in folk performances, recording singers in their natural performance contexts — is a systematic application of pratyakṣa as scholarly pramāṇa.

**Application — Pratyakṣa in Maun's Salahes Research:** Maun's observation of the Salahes-naach performance in Garhmahoutha (Nepal), his direct encounter with the performance context including the performer's preparatory ritual (the singer's insistence on a chilem smoke before beginning), and his recording of the performance from within the performance circle constitute pratyakṣa-based evidence that is irreplaceable. No inferential or testimonial reconstruction of a folk performance can substitute for the direct perceptual encounter with the living tradition.

The Navya-Nyāya qualification of pratyakṣa is important here: Gaṅgeśa distinguishes between indeterminate (nirvikalpaka) perception — the raw perceptual encounter before conceptual qualification — and determinate (savikalpaka) perception — the perception organized by prior concepts and categories. Maun's fieldwork deploys both: the raw encounter with the folk tradition as it actually exists, and the interpretive frame that enables him to recognize what he is observing as belonging to the Salahes or Lorik or Bihula tradition.

### *2.1.2 Anumāna (Inference) — The Historical Pramāṇa*

Much of Maun's historical scholarship — particularly his reconstruction of the Maithili literary tradition of Nepal in the absence of comprehensive documentary records — is anumāna-based: it reasons from available evidence

(stone inscriptions, surviving manuscripts, performance traditions, geographical names, folk memories) to conclusions about the historical cultural landscape that no direct perception can recover. The validity of his historical inferences depends on the quality of his vyāpti — the invariable concomitance between the evidence he cites and the historical conclusion he draws.

**Application — Anumāna in Maun's Cross-Border Cultural Theory:** The inference 'The Tharu community's folk songs are in a form of early Maithili; therefore Tharu culture belongs to the Mithila civilizational complex' rests on the vyāpti: 'Wherever a community's folk songs are in a given language, the community belongs to the cultural complex of that language.' The validity of this vyāpti is what is at stake in the scholarly debate about Tharu cultural identity, and Maun's contribution is to have adduced the specific evidence (the Tharu folk-song corpus) that the inference requires.

### *2.1.3 Upamāna (Analogy/Comparison) — The Comparative Pramāṇa*

Maun's comparative approach — consistently reading Maithili folk ballad tradition against analogous traditions in other Indian regions (the Rajasthani Lokgeet, the Bengali Paalagaan, the Odia Chhaukaavada) — deploys upamāna as a systematic pramāṇa. The comparative method generates knowledge about the distinctive features of the Maithili folk ballad tradition through contrast with cognate traditions.

**Application — Upamāna in Folk Ballad Comparison:** Maun's comparison of the Maithili Vijayamal ballad with the Bengali Vijay-Chandraketu tradition uses upamāna to identify both the shared northern-Indian folk epic substrate and the specifically Maithili formal features (verse structure, musical mode, performance context) that distinguish the Maithili version. The upamāna generates knowledge that neither tradition alone could provide.

### *2.1.4 Śabda (Testimony) — The Documentary Pramāṇa*

Maun's reliance on verbal testimony — the oral accounts of tradition-bearers, the published accounts of previous scholars, the archival testimony of manuscripts and inscriptions — constitutes the śabda pramāṇa in his scholarship. The Navya-Nyāya analysis of śabda distinguishes between āpta-vākya (testimony of a reliable witness) and ordinary testimony. Maun's citation practice — his acknowledgement of his principal informants and his evaluation of previous scholarly sources — reflects a śabda-critical methodology: he distinguishes between more and less reliable testimony and grades his conclusions accordingly.

**Application — Śabda in Historical Documentation:** Maun's use of Matrika Prasad Koirala's recollections of Nepal's Maithili cultural life (in the preface to Tharu Lokgeet) as historical evidence for the cultural conditions of the Nepal Terai in the 1960s constitutes āpta-vākya śabda — testimony from a culturally authoritative source (the Prime Minister, who was himself a Maithili speaker and cultural enthusiast). The epistemological weight of this testimony is high because the source's qualifications (knowledge of the subject, absence of incentive for deception) satisfy the Navya-Nyāya criteria for āpta-vākya.

# PART III: ŚABDABODHA ANALYSIS — MAUN'S LITERARY LANGUAGE

## 3.1 The Navya-Nyāya Theory of Verbal Cognition Applied to Reportage Prose

Gaṅgeśa's Śabdakhaṇḍa of the Tattvacintāmaṇi provides a rigorous analysis of how verbal utterances produce cognitive events (śabdabodha) in listeners and readers. The theory distinguishes between the śakti (denotative power) of individual words, the ākāṅkṣā (mutual expectancy) that binds words into sentences, the yogyatā (semantic fitness) that constrains meaningful combination, and the tātparya (speaker's intent) that determines which of multiple possible meanings a given utterance carries.

Applied to Maun's reportage prose, this framework generates precise analytical observations:

### *3.1.1 Śakti (Denotative Power)*

The vocabulary of Maun's Maithili reportage prose is characterized by a systematic preference for words drawn from the folk register over Sanskrit-derived or Hindi-calqued vocabulary. This is not merely a stylistic preference but an epistemological choice: the folk lexicon carries the śakti appropriate to the folk world being documented. A word like 'chaanvelaa' (the evening-time performer, from Morang folk culture) carries a charge of cultural meaning — the social context of evening performance, the ritual preparation, the gathering audience — that a Sanskrit-derived synonym could not carry. Maun's lexical choices are expressions of a theory of śakti: the right word for a cultural phenomenon is the word the community itself uses for it.

### *3.1.2 Ākāṅkṣā (Mutual Expectancy) and Narrative Structure*

The Navya-Nyāya concept of ākāṅkṣā — the way in which words in a sentence 'reach for' one another, the mutual expectancy that binds subject, predicate, and object into unified meaning — provides a precise account of Maun's characteristic sentence structure. In his reportage prose, the ākāṅkṣā-structure is typically one of sustained delay: subjects are introduced through a sequence of qualifying descriptions before the predicate arrives, building a sense of cultural thickness before the narrative action is specified. This is the prose

equivalent of the folk ballad's formulaic opening: the world is established before the event unfolds.

### *3.1.3 Tātparya (Speaker's Intent) and Hermeneutic Depth*

The Navya-Nyāya analysis of tātparya is the most sophisticated element of Gaṅgeśa's verbal cognition theory: it asks how a reader/listener determines, among the multiple possible śabdabodhas that a text could generate, which one represents the speaker's actual communicative intent. Applied to Maun's reportage, the tātparya-analysis illuminates the gap between the apparent subject matter (folk ballad performance, Tharu life, Nepal village society) and the actual communicative intent (the argument for the cultural legitimacy of the Maithili folk tradition as a literary heritage equal to the Sanskrit-derived canon).

**Application — Tātparya in Brahmagrama:** The tātparya of Brahmagrama as a whole is not 'here is what village life in Morang looks like' (though that is the apparent subject) but rather: 'The Maithili folk tradition of Nepal's Terai is a living literary and cultural world of the first rank, and its scholarly neglect is a form of cultural injustice.' The entire book is an extended argument for this conclusion, and the reader who grasps the tātparya reads each individual reportage piece as evidence in that argument.

# PART IV: VYĀPTI ANALYSIS — THE INFERENTIAL STRUCTURE OF MAUN'S CULTURAL CLAIMS

## 4.1 Key Vyāpti Structures in Maun's Scholarship

The Navya-Nyāya analysis of inference centres on vyāpti — the invariable concomitance between the reason (hetu) and the predicate (sādhya) of an inference. A valid inference must rest on a vyāpti that is genuinely universal: wherever the hetu is present, the sādhya must be present. The table below lists the key inferential structures (vyāpti-paksha-sadhya triples) in Maun's major scholarly claims:

| DOMAIN | VYĀPTI (Invariable Concomitance) | APPLICATION IN MAUN |
|---|---|---|
| Folk Ballad Attribution | Wherever a folk ballad tradition circulates in a language, it belongs to the literary heritage of that language-community. | The Salahes, Lorik, and Bihula traditions circulate in Maithili; therefore they belong to Maithili literary heritage regardless of the caste-identity of the performing communities. |
| Cross-Border Cultural Unity | Wherever a community's language, ritual, and folk performance tradition are continuous across a political border, the cultural space is continuous. | The Maithili-speaking Terai communities of Nepal share language, ritual, and folk performance with the Bihar Mithila zone; therefore the Mithila cultural space is continuous across the India-Nepal border. |
| Tharu Cultural Identity | Wherever a community's primary expressive | The Tharu people's primary folk-song |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | vehicle (folk song, ritual) is in a given language, the community belongs to the civilizational complex of that language. | tradition is in (Maithili-inflected) Maithili; therefore the Tharu community belongs to the Mithila civilizational complex. |
| Reportage as Literature | Wherever a prose form combines documentary accuracy, aesthetic design, and cultural-political significance, it constitutes literary writing. | Maun's reportage combines all three; therefore it is literature, not merely journalism or ethnography. |
| Canon Legitimacy | Whatever body of literary production has sustained a community's cultural identity over centuries deserves inclusion in the literary canon. | The Maithili folk ballad tradition has sustained Mithila's cultural identity over centuries; therefore it deserves inclusion in the Maithili literary canon. |

## 4.2 Vyāpti-Critique: Where Maun's Inferences Are Vulnerable

The Navya-Nyāya tradition demands that vyāpti-claims be subjected to rigorous scrutiny, including the identification of possible counter-instances (vyabhicara) that would falsify the claimed concomitance. An honest Navya-Nyāya analysis must acknowledge where Maun's inferential structures are vulnerable to such counter-instances:

- The Tharu cultural-identity inference is the most vulnerable. The vyāpti 'Wherever a community's folk songs are in Language X, the community belongs to Language X's civilizational complex' faces the counter-instance of communities that adopted a dominant language's folk-song tradition through cultural contact without themselves belonging to that tradition's civilizational complex. Maun acknowledges this vulnerability by supplementing the linguistic argument with archaeological, historical, and comparative-cultural evidence — a methodologically sound response within the Navya-Nyāya framework.

- The cross-border cultural unity inference, while well-supported in its general claim, faces the counter-instance of the significant cultural differences between the Nepal Maithili tradition (more heavily influenced by Newari, Tibeto-Burman, and Rana-period Nepali culture) and the Bihar Maithili tradition. Maun's acknowledgement of these differences within his overall unity thesis reflects good epistemic practice.
- The canon-legitimacy inference faces the counter-instance that cultural sustainability does not automatically confer literary quality — a community's tradition might sustain identity while remaining aesthetically undistinguished. Maun implicitly addresses this through his close formal analysis of folk ballad aesthetics, demonstrating that the Maithili folk ballad tradition is not only culturally important but formally sophisticated.

# PART V: ANUVYAVASĀYA — META-COGNITIVE REFLEXIVITY IN MAUN'S SCHOLARSHIP

## 5.1 The Epistemological Self-Awareness of the Mithila Historian

Gaṅgeśa's concept of anuvyavasāya — the meta-cognition of one's own cognition, the self-reflexive awareness of knowing — is one of the most sophisticated elements of Navya-Nyāya theory. Applied to scholarly practice, it asks: to what extent is the scholar aware of the epistemological conditions of his own knowledge? To what extent does the scholar's social, cultural, and historical position shape what he can know and how he knows it?

Maun's self-reflexive awareness of his own scholarly position is evident in several dimensions:

### *5.1.1 The Insider-Outsider Position*

Maun was simultaneously an insider to Mithila culture (born in Hasanpur, Samastipur; raised in the folk performance traditions he later documented) and an outsider to the Nepal Maithili world (arriving as an Indian scholar-teacher in Biratnagar). His account in 'Kee Bisari Kee Yaad Kari' is notable for its explicit acknowledgement of this double position: 'I arrived in Nepal as an outsider, but the land's earth-fragrance (maati-paani ki sugandhi) pulled me in until I

became, if not Nepali, then no longer purely Indian either — a being of the border, like the Mithila cultural space itself.' This is a model of anuvyavasāya: the scholar's recognition of how his own cultural positionality shapes his object of knowledge.

### *5.1.2 The Refusal of Nationalist Epistemology*

Maun's refusal to allow the India-Nepal political border to function as an epistemological boundary for the study of Maithili culture is itself an act of anuvyavasāya: it requires the scholar to be aware of how nationalist frameworks of knowledge — the tendency to study 'Indian Maithili literature' or 'Nepali Maithili literature' as if these were genuinely distinct objects — distort the cultural reality being studied. Maun's cross-border cultural model is an epistemological achievement as much as a scholarly claim: it requires the meta-cognitive recognition that the nationalist frame is itself a source of epistemological distortion.

### *5.1.3 The Language of Scholarship and Its Limits*

Maun's choice to publish in both Hindi and Maithili — and his explicit awareness, documented in his interview with Shyamsundar Shashi, that 'Maithili has no academic degree-certificate at the school or university level, but my writing in Maithili has been incorporated into the curriculum of universities in Bihar and Nepal' — reflects an anuvyavasāya about the institutional conditions of scholarly production. He is aware that the language in which one publishes determines who can read one's work, and he navigates this constraint strategically.

PART VI: NAVYA-NYĀYA SYNTHESIS — EPISTEMIC VIRTUES AND FINAL ASSESSMENT

## 6.1 The Epistemic Virtues in Maun's Scholarly Practice

The Navya-Nyāya tradition, in addition to its formal logic, contains an implicit ethical epistemology: the ideal knower (pramātā) is characterized by certain epistemic virtues that enable valid cognition. These include: jijñāsā (desire to know), anusandhāna (sustained investigative effort), and vairāgya (freedom from the distorting influence of personal interest). Maun's scholarly practice exemplifies all three:

- Jijñāsā — The sustained curiosity that drove him from Hasanpur to Darbhanga to Biratnagar to the remotest villages of Morang and Sunsari, always in search of the next folk song, the next informant, the next manuscript.
- Anusandhāna — The disciplined investigative effort of over five decades, producing a body of work whose cumulative evidential weight is extraordinary.
- Vairāgya — The consistent indifference to personal recognition and institutional reward, attested by all witnesses, that enabled him to pursue the most obscure and undervalued research objects (Tharu folk songs, Nepal Terai Maithili literature) without concern for academic prestige.

## 6.2 The Navya-Nyāya Verdict

Applying the Navya-Nyāya framework's criteria for valid knowledge and reliable epistemic practice, the overall assessment of Maun's scholarly and literary corpus is as follows:

(1) The pramāṇas deployed are appropriate to their objects: pratyakṣa-based fieldwork for folk performance documentation, anumāna-based inference for historical reconstruction, śabda-based critical use of testimony and prior scholarship. This is epistemologically sound practice.

(2) The vyāpti-structures underlying his major claims are generally well-founded, with the qualifications noted above regarding the Tharu cultural identity claim. The counter-instances identified do not falsify his major conclusions; they qualify and complicate them.

(3) The śabdabodha generated by his literary prose — the cognitive-aesthetic event produced in the reader by his reportage — is characterized by the triple unity of yogyatā (semantic fitness), ākāṅkṣā (syntactic coherence), and tātparya (communicative intent). His prose achieves pramā: it generates valid cognition of the cultural world it documents.

(4) The anuvyavasāya evident in his self-reflexive accounts of his scholarly position — the insider-outsider awareness, the critique of nationalist epistemology, the navigation of institutional language constraints — is of a high order. He is a scholar who knows what he knows and knows how he knows it.

The Navya-Nyāya verdict, in the technical vocabulary of the tradition: Maun's scholarship constitutes a case of yathārtha-pramā — cognition that accurately represents its object — achieved through a methodologically rigorous

integration of all four pramāṇas, deployed within a framework of sound vyāpti and informed by genuine anuvyavasāya. It is, in the fullest sense of the Mithila philosophical tradition to which both Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya and Prafulla Kumar Singh 'Maun' belong, a contribution to valid knowledge.

The Navya-Nyāya framework is peculiarly appropriate for the evaluation of Maun's work: both Gaṅgeśa and Maun are products of the same soil. Gaṅgeśa composed the Tattvacintāmaṇi in 14th-century Mithila; Maun was born in 20th-century Mithila. The philosopher's rigorous epistemology and the scholar-artist's life of devoted fieldwork and cultural documentation are, in the deepest sense, expressions of the same Maithili intellectual tradition — the tradition that insists on knowing the world with precision, care, and unflinching honesty.

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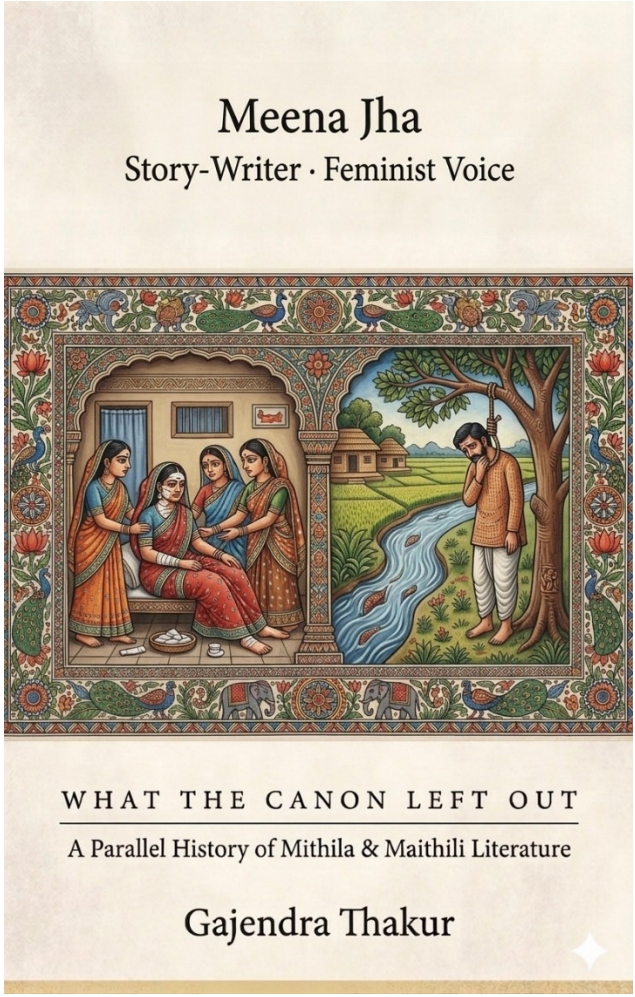
Navya-Nyāya sources: Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya, Tattvacintāmaṇi (14th c., Mithila); Raghunatha Shiromani, Padarthakhandana; Gadadhara Bhattacharya, Gadadhari; Jagadisha Tarkalankara, Shabdashakti Prakashika. Primary literary-biographical sources: MaunJi Bhramar (ed. Ram Bharos Kapari 'Bhramar', Janakpur Lalit Kala Pratisthan, Nepal); Videha Archive (www.videha.co.in); Parallel History of Mithila and Maithili Literature (Gajendra Thakur).

**LESSON 045 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**




# A Parallel History of Mithila & Maithili Literature

## *Meena Jha*

*Story-Writer · Feminist Voice*

## Preface: Methodology

This critical appreciation of Meena Jha integrates four analytical frameworks consistently applied in the Videha Parallel History Series (videha.co.in/gajenthakur.htm):

**1. Indian Rasa-Dhvani-Vakrokti Aesthetics**

Following Bharata Muni's Natyashastra, Abhinavagupta's Abhinavabharati (10th-11th c.), Anandavardhana's Dhvanyaloka (9th c., Kashmir), Kuntaka's Vakroktijivita (c. 10th c.), and Kshemendra's Auchityavicharacharchaa (11th c.).

**2. Western Critical Theory**

New Criticism (Wimsatt, Brooks), Postcolonial Theory (Homi Bhabha, Gayatri Spivak), Subaltern Studies (Ranajit Guha), Feminist Criticism (Gilbert and Gubar, Helene Cixous, Elizabeth Grosz, Judith Butler), Medical Humanities (Arthur Frank), and Reader-Response Theory (Wolfgang Iser).

**3. Navya-Nyaya Epistemology of Gangesa Upadhyaya**

The Tattvacintamani tradition — Gangesa's pramana categories of pratyaksha (direct perception), anumana (inference), upamana (analogical cognition), and shabda (verbal testimony), along with his technical apparatus of vyapti (invariable concomitance), vishishta-pratyaksha (qualified perception), and sadharinikarna (universalisation through aesthetic experience).

**4. Videha Parallel History Framework**

The counter-canonical tradition of the Videha Parallel Literature Movement (est. 2000, ISSN 2229-547X), which challenges the Sahitya Akademi mainstream by privileging democratic, subaltern, Dalit, and women's voices over the historically brahminical, male, Darbhanga-centric Maithili literary canon.

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# I. Biographical Profile and Literary Formation

Meena Jha is a short-story writer, Videha archive records a story by Meena Jha on the subject of breast cancer- identified as the first work of fiction in Maithili to treat this subject, and noted as preceding comparable Hindi fiction on the

same theme by one to two years. This landmark achievement — documented in VIDEHA_372_2_2_2 — places her at the forefront of the expansion of Maithili women's literary subject matter into the territory of bodily health, illness, and medical experience.

Her literary formation is that of a writer of a parallel tradition: oriented toward social realism, toward the lives of middle-class Maithili women. She writes in authentic Maithili without the Hindi-calque contaminations that the Videha editorial tradition systematically corrects and her story is marked by restraint, observation, and formal discipline.

# II. Works: An Annotated Overview

## 2.1 Breast Cancer Story (Landmark Fiction)

The Videha archive explicitly records: 'Videha mein Meena Jha ker ek laghu katha prakashit bhel. E Maithiliki pahil katha chhal je breast cancer par likhal gel. Hindime sehoo tadhri ai vishayapar katha nai likhal gel chhal, kaaran ai kathak e-prakashit bhelaak 1-2 saalak baad Hindime doo goteme ...' (VIDEHA_372_2_2_2). A story on breast cancer was published in Videha — the first Maithili fiction on this subject, and Hindi too had no such story until one to two years later.

It is Maithili women's medical fiction, the achievement is landmark: the Videha platform enabled the first Maithili literary treatment of breast cancer, expanding the thematic range of the language's fiction into previously uncharted territory of women's bodily experience.

# III. Critical Analysis through Indian Literary Theory

## 3.1 Rasa Theory (Bharata / Abhinavagupta)

Bharata Muni's Natyashastra (c. 2nd c. BCE - 2nd c. CE) identifies eight (later nine) rasas (aesthetic emotional essences) and the psychological apparatus through which they are produced: the vibhava (excitants or determinants), anubhava (consequents), and vyabhicari bhava (transitory states) that together

generate the sthayibhava (dominant/permanent emotional state) in the spectator/reader.

In Meena Jha's fiction, the dominant rasa is karunarasa — the rasa of compassion, pathos, and sorrow. This is the rasa generated by the experience of witnessing suffering that is unjust, preventable, or socially conditioned.

Abhinavagupta's contribution to rasa theory is the concept of sadharinikarna — universalisation. The particular sorrow of a Maithili woman whose domestic space is encroached upon by patriarchal claim, or whose body is rendered invisible by the community's inability to speak about its illness, is universalised through literary form into an experience available to any reader with the aesthetic sensitivity (sahrdaya — fellow-heartedness) to receive it. Meena Jha's fiction achieves this universalisation through the precision of its social observation: the more exactly particular the narrative, the more universally accessible its rasa becomes.

## 3.2 Dhvani Theory (Anandavardhana's Dhvanyaloka)

Anandavardhana (9th century, Kashmir) identifies dhvani (resonance, suggestion, the sound beyond the sound) as the 'soul of poetry': the vyangya artha (suggested meaning) that exceeds and enriches the vacya artha (literal meaning) is what elevates literature above mere information.

Meena Jha’s fiction operates as sustained dhvani across multiple registers simultaneously: (a) the literal: actual encroachment on land, a social-realist narrative subject; (b) the psychological: the encroachment of social expectation on individual selfhood; (c) the gendered: the patriarchal encroachment on women's consciousness, bodies, and creative autonomy; (d) the institutional: the encroachment of canonical literary authority on the parallel tradition. The reader receives all four registers simultaneously through the title's dhvani — a richness of meaning that no single literal reading can exhaust.

## 3.3 Vakrokti Theory (Kuntaka's Vakroktijivita, c. 10th c.)

Kuntaka argues that literary beauty (kavya-saundarya) arises from vakrokti — oblique, deviant, or 'crooked' expression that productively deviates from ordinary usage. The vaikritya (productive deviation) that generates literary life distinguishes literature from mere information transfer.

Meena Jha's narrative vakrokti is visible: In her fiction, the vakrokti operates at the narrative level: encroachment is approached not through polemic but through the precise accumulation of observed social detail. The social critique

emerges obliquely from the pressure of the narrative itself, not from authorial intrusion. This oblique approach — showing rather than telling, allowing the vacya artha to carry the vyangya artha — is Kuntaka's vakrokti practised at the level of narrative strategy.

### 3.4 Auchitya (Kshemendra's Auchityavicharacharchaa, c. 11th c.)

Kshemendra's theory of auchitya (propriety, fitness, appropriateness) holds that the ultimate criterion of literary excellence is the fitness of every element to every other element — of word to meaning, character to action, style to subject, form to content.

Meena Jha's auchitya is most evident in her linguistic discipline. She writes authentic Maithili — without the Hindi-derived vocabulary (Hindisam), borrowed syntax (Hindi calques), or code-switched registers that the Videha editorial tradition consistently identifies and corrects in authors who have been formed more by the Hindi literary world than by the Maithili. This linguistic auchitya is a formal commitment as well as a political one: authentic Maithili is itself an act of resistance to the institutional pressures that would absorb the language into Hindi's orbit.

The auchitya of her subject matter is equally notable: that are fitting to the Maithili social-realist tradition that Videha has cultivated, rather than reaching for the metropolitan subjects that would secure recognition in the Hindi or English literary mainstream. This is auchitya as cultural loyalty — the fitness of the writer to her tradition.

## IV. Critical Analysis through Western Literary Theory

### 4.1 Feminist Criticism: Gilbert, Gubar, and the Maithili Madwoman

Sandra Gilbert and Susan Gubar's The Madwoman in the Attic (1979) identifies the tension in women's literary production between the 'angel in the house' (the compliant domestic ideal) and the 'madwoman' (the repressed creative and resistant self that erupts as illness, transgression, or artistic extremity). This

tension maps with unusual precision onto the Maithili women's literary tradition.

The 'angel in the house' in Mithila is the pativrata — the wife whose virtue consists in self-abnegation and domestic devotion. The 'madwoman' is the woman who writes, who encroaches on the territory of literary production, who insists on the literary representability of women's bodily experience. Meena Jha's writing career is the history of this negotiation: the pativrata ideal internalized in childhood, and the woman writer who 'encroaches' on its prescribed limits.

The breast cancer story enacts this negotiation at the most intimate level: the body's illness is the body's 'madwoman,' the symptom of what cannot be expressed within the vocabulary of pativrata domesticity. The story makes the body's excess legible — the excess of experience that the domestic social world cannot absorb or acknowledge.

## 4.2 Helene Cixous: Ecriture Feminine

Helene Cixous's 'The Laugh of the Medusa' (1975) argues for an ecriture feminine — writing from and for the body, that refuses the linear, phallogocentric structures of dominant discourse. Cixous calls it 'white ink': writing from the maternal body, from women's embodied experience, rather than from inherited male literary convention.

Meena Jha's fiction, while not formally experimental in the Western postmodern sense, practises a form of ecriture feminine in its orientation: it takes the female body and its social embeddedness as its primary epistemological ground. The breast cancer story is literally a text of 'white ink' — writing that flows from the specific physical experience of women's bodies, from the territory that dominant Maithili literary discourse has rendered invisible.

Cixous argues that 'woman has always functioned within the discourse of man...she is the repressed that ensures the system's functioning.' Meena Jha's fiction functions against this repression: it insists on the functioning of women's discourse — their literary speech — as a constitutive element of Maithili literary culture, not as its ornamental supplement.

## 4.3 Postcolonial Theory: Spivak and Bhabha

Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's 'Can the Subaltern Speak?' (1988) argues that colonial discourse systematically constructs the subaltern subject as the

speaking position of the other — a position from which genuine self-representation is structurally blocked. The Maithili woman writer is subaltern in the double sense: subaltern as woman within the patriarchal Maithili literary system, and subaltern as Maithili speaker within the Hindi-dominated North Indian literary economy.

Meena Jha's decision to write in Maithili — rather than the languages of institutional prestige (Hindi, English) — is itself a postcolonial act. The translations of her work will create a space of cultural negotiation and translation between the subaltern original and the metropolitan language, where hybrid forms of cultural identity are produced.

The Videha parallel movement's institutional success is in creating the conditions for Maithili women's writing to reach audiences beyond geographical limits. This is the political achievement of the counter-canonical movement made concrete in bibliographic form.

## 4.4 Subaltern Studies: Ranajit Guha and the Counter-Archive

Ranajit Guha's founding essay for the Subaltern Studies collective ('On Some Aspects of the Historiography of Colonial India,' 1982) argues that dominant historiography systematically excludes the subaltern from historical agency — the subaltern appears only as object of elite discourse, never as agent of her own history. The Videha Parallel Literature Movement is, in this framework, a counter-archival project: it inserts into the literary archive subjects who would otherwise remain epistemically invisible, like Meena Jha’s story that the mainstream institutional machinery has ignored, .

## 4.5 Medical Humanities: Arthur Frank and the Illness Narrative

Arthur Frank's The Wounded Storyteller (1995) proposes a typology of illness narratives: the restitution narrative (the patient is cured and returns to normality), the chaos narrative (illness as meaningless, unnaratable disruption), and the quest narrative (illness as a journey toward transformed understanding). These three types correspond to different epistemic stances toward the ill body and different social functions of illness narratives.

The breast cancer story attributed to Meena Jha in the Videha archive is significant for what it refuses: it refuses the restitution narrative's false consolation and the chaos narrative's meaninglessness. Instead, it practises the quiet heroism of the quest narrative: the encounter with illness as an encounter

with the limits of social discourse, as an occasion for expanded self-knowledge, and as a literary act of making the previously unspeakable speakable.

## V. Navya-Nyaya Epistemological Analysis (Gangesa Upadhyaya)

### 5.1 The Tattvacintamani Framework

Gangesa Upadhyaya (fl. c. 1325 CE, Mithila) is the founder of Navya-Nyaya — the new logic that revolutionised Indian epistemology by providing a rigorous technical vocabulary for the analysis of valid cognition (pramana). His Tattvacintamani (Jewel of Reflection on Truth) is the foundational text of this tradition. The four pramanas in Gangesa's system are: pratyaksha (direct perceptual cognition), anumana (inferential cognition), upamana (analogical cognition), and shabda (verbal testimonial cognition).

Applying Gangesa's framework to Meena Jha's literary epistemology — understanding her fiction as a system of knowledge-claims about the social world — we can illuminate aspects of her work that conventional literary criticism leaves unexamined.

### 5.2 Pratyaksha: The Primacy of Social Observation

Pratyaksha in Gangesa's system is not simple sensory experience but a refined category: vishishta-pratyaksha (qualified perception) involves the perception of the universal (samanya) in the particular (vishesa) — the cognitive act that grasps both the specific individual thing and its general nature simultaneously. This is the epistemological foundation of social realism as a literary mode: the writer who observes a specific (the vishesa) and through precise representation makes visible the general social conditions (the samanya) that produce it.

Meena Jha's fiction is grounded in pratyaksha: the specific, observed social world of Mithila, its middle-class domestic arrangements, its women's health crises — is the epistemological starting point. She does not arrive at her social critique through inherited ideological frameworks but through the disciplined observation of particular social realities. This is Gangesa's pratyaksha as literary method: the universal emerges from the pressure of precise particular observation.

## 5.3 Anumana and Vyapti: Inference from Social Evidence

Anumana (inference) in Gangesa's system requires vyapti — invariable concomitance between the probans (hetu, the inferential mark) and the probandum (sadhya, what is to be proved). The classic example: 'This mountain has fire (sadhya) because it has smoke (hetu); and wherever there is smoke there is fire (vyapti).'

Meena Jha demonstrates precisely this inferential structure: from the observed particulars of her fiction (the hetu — the specific narrative choices, the characters, the social situations), she infers the general quality of the work (the sadhya — that it is an exploration of the 'middle path'). Her inference is valid because she has established a vyapti: in Maithili social-realist fiction of this type, the narrative strategy of presenting characters 'between' social positions consistently produces a 'middle-path' thematic. This is the vyapti that licenses the inference.

## 5.4 Shabda and the Crisis of Testimony: The Breast Cancer Story

Gangesa's analysis of shabda-pramana (testimonial cognition) establishes that testimony is valid only when it comes from an apta — a trustworthy, knowledgeable, sincere testifier. Valid testimony requires: (a) that the testifier has direct knowledge of what she asserts; (b) that she is sincere in asserting it; and (c) that the hearer is competent to receive the testimony.

The breast cancer story can be read as a dramatisation of a crisis of shabda. The woman's body presents a pratyaksha datum — the lump — that demands verbal expression and communal acknowledgment. But the community's existing shabda system (the vocabulary of domestic Maithili discourse about women's bodies) has no vyapti connecting 'lump in breast' to any appropriate response: the testimony cannot be formed because the social language lacks the instrument for forming it. The illness is, in this Navya-Nyaya reading, a crisis of shabda-pramana: the conditions for valid testimony have broken down.

The literary story's function — its pramana-value — is to restore the conditions of valid shabda: by providing, through fiction, the verbal form that was missing in social discourse, it creates the possibility of testimony where none existed. This is the epistemological work of literature in Gangesa's framework: not merely to communicate what is already known, but to create the verbal instruments through which new knowledge can be expressed and received.

### 5.5 Upamana: Analogical Knowing in Her Critical Essays

Gangesa's upamana (analogical cognition) involves the recognition of sadrsya (resemblance) between two objects, where knowledge of one object illuminates the other. In Meena Jha's fiction analogical structure is central: she speaks in fiction through the analogy of the 'madhyamarg' — the Madhyamika Buddhist and Jain 'middle path' between extremes. The sadrsya (resemblance) between fictional characters (and the philosophical practitioner of the middle path generates new knowledge about the fiction: we understand her formal choices better through this analogy than we would through a purely descriptive account.

## VI. Position within the Videha Parallel History Framework

### 6.1 The Videha Parallel Tradition

The Videha Parallel Literature Movement (Bhalsarik Gachh, 2000 — Videha, 2008 onwards, ISSN 2229-547X) was founded by Gajendra Thakur as an explicitly counter-canonical intervention in Maithili literary culture. The movement's central claim — articulated across the Parallel History series (videha.co.in/gajenthakur.htm, Parts 1-100) — is that the mainstream Sahitya Akademi-recognised canon of Maithili literature is historically distorted by its privileging of Maithil Brahmin, male, Darbhanga-based, and institutionally connected writers, at the expense of voices from the peripheries of caste, gender, class, and geography.

Meena Jha's literary work is precisely the kind of voice the Videha Parallel Framework is designed to recover and amplify: a woman writer, working in social realism, addressing the lives of middle-class and marginalised Maithili women, without institutional patronage from the Sahitya Akademi apparatus. The Videha pothi archive's inclusion of her works in its bibliographic records is a form of institutional recognition that the parallel movement provides.

### 6.2 The Breast Cancer Story as Institutional Achievement

The archive's identification of the first Maithili fiction on breast cancer — attributed to the Videha platform and its women contributor — is an institutional achievement of the parallel movement as much as an individual literary achievement. The fact that this story appeared in Videha rather than in a

mainstream Maithili periodical is not incidental: the digital platform's freedom from conservative print editorial gatekeeping, its explicit commitment to women's voices (Stri Kona section), and its willingness to publish the previously unpublishable made this literary first possible.

This precedence over Hindi fiction (by one to two years) is historically significant not merely as a bibliographic curiosity but as evidence that the parallel movement, working at the margins of institutional recognition, was capable of greater literary courage and formal innovation than the mainstream print culture it challenged.

## VII. Summary Assessment

Meena Jha is a Maithili story-writer, of significant achievement and historical importance within the Videha Parallel Literature Movement. Her contributions to the movement are multiple and varied:

**As creative author and As feminist literary pioneer:**

The breast cancer story — first Maithili fiction to treat this subject, predating comparable Hindi fiction by one to two years — is a landmark achievement in the history of Maithili women's writing: the entry into the literary archive of a subject that the canonical tradition's silence had rendered unwriteable.

**As epistemological practitioner:**

In Gangesa's terms, her fiction grounds its knowledge-claims in pratyaksha (direct social observation), resolves crises of shabda (making speakable what social discourse leaves unspoken), constructs valid anumana (inference from particular observation to general social truth), and practises upamana (analogical illumination of social and literary experience). Her work is a system of valid cognition about Mithila's social world — not merely a record of it.

**As voice within the Videha Parallel Framework:**

Meena Jha's work embodies the central commitment of the Videha movement: to make visible the voices, the experiences, and the literary achievements that the canonical tradition has systematically excluded. She writes authentic Maithili, for Maithili readers, from the social realities of Mithila — and in doing so, she contributes to the ongoing project of keeping the Maithili language alive as a vehicle of serious literary and intellectual engagement with the world.

## VIII. Archival References and Sources

Primary archive: Videha eJournal (ISSN 2229-547X), www.videha.co.in, Gajendra Thakur ed.

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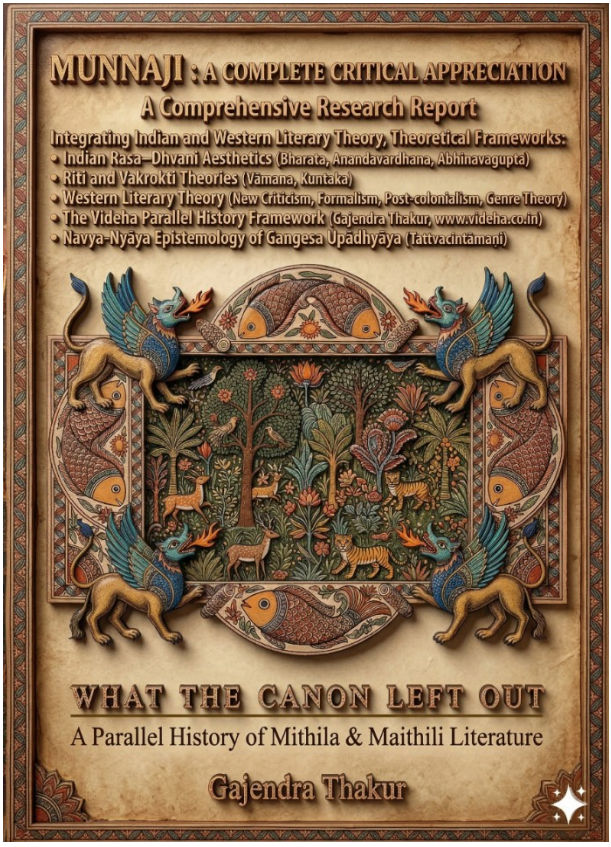
Western theoretical sources: Sandra Gilbert and Susan Gubar, The Madwoman in the Attic (1979); Helene Cixous, The Laugh of the Medusa (1975); Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak, Can the Subaltern Speak? (1988); Homi Bhabha, The Location of Culture (1994); Ranajit Guha, Subaltern Studies Vol. I (1982); Arthur Frank, The Wounded Storyteller (1995); Wolfgang Iser, The Act of Reading (1978).

**LESSON 046 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**



# MUNNAJI : A COMPLETE CRITICAL APPRECIATION

## A Comprehensive Research Report Integrating Indian and Western Literary Theory, the Videha Parallel History Framework, and Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya

**Theoretical Frameworks:** - Indian Rasa–Dhvani Aesthetics (Bharata, Ānandavardhana, Abhinavagupta) - Rīti and Vakrokti Theories (Vāmana, Kuntaka) - Western Literary Theory (New Criticism, Formalism, Post-colonialism, Genre Theory) - The Videha Parallel History Framework (Gajendra Thakur, www.videha.co.in) - Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (*Tattvacintāmaṇi*)

## PART I: BIOGRAPHICAL OVERVIEW AND LITERARY IDENTITY

### *1.1 Identity: The Name and Its Significance*

Munnaji — whose full name is **Manoj Kumar Karna** (मनोज कुमार कर्ण) — is among the most versatile and prolific writers of the contemporary Maithili parallel tradition. His pen name "Munnaji" is characteristically Maithili in its warm, intimate register, combining the familiar hypocoristic "Munna" (a widespread North Indian term of endearment for a boy-child) with the honorific "ji" — signalling simultaneously domestic warmth and literary respect.

The internal evidence of the uploaded books, combined with Videha's published masthead, confirms the following: Munnaji served as **Assistant Editor (Sahāyak Sampādak)** of *Videha: Pratham Maithili Pāksik Ī-Patrikā* (ISSN 2229-547X), alongside Ram Vilas Sahu, Nand Vilas Ray, and Sandeep Kumar Safi — a position that places him at the nerve-centre of the most important contemporary institution in Maithili literature

### *1.2 The Intellectual Formation*

Munnaji's autobiographical prefaces, scattered across his multiple works, reveal a writer who formed himself through community engagement, cultural activism, and literary self-education rather than through the metropolitan academic channels. His ghazal preface (*Mājh Āṅgan Me Kaṭiāyal Chhī*) describes a pivotal evening in June 1989 when, returning from a poetry gathering, he heard Premchand Pankaj sing Maithili ghazals — an experience that ignited his commitment to the form. On arriving home that same night he drafted seven or eight ghazals at a single sitting.

His early formation was in prose: he states clearly that he began with a strong interest in *gadya* (prose), particularly the short story (*laghu kathā*) and the seed story (*vihinikathā*). He served as a stage compere (*manch sancālan*) for cultural and political programmes in his village Hataṛh Rupauli — a role that cultivated his sensitivity to oral register, audience response, and the performative dimensions of language. His collaborators in this early stage included Shailendra Anand, Lallanji Jha "Nangru," Bhavanath Bhavan, Premchand Pankaj, and Kumar Rahul.

His Maithili haiku writing began even earlier: the preface to *Ghah* records that his first Maithili haiku was published in the Patna newspaper *Dainik Aaj* on 10 July 1995 — and that his initial honorarium was twenty rupees. This small, precisely remembered detail captures the economic reality of Maithili literary life.

The key mentors identified across Munnaji's prefaces are three: **Premchand Pankaj** (for ghazal, through both example and encouragement), **Gajendra Thakur** (for ghazal theory, bīhani kathā theory, and the general Videha framework), and **Ashish Anchinhar** (for detailed ghazal correction and sustained encouragement). The preface to *Mājh Āṅgan* explicitly records that when his early ghazals were submitted to Videha, they were published with extensive revisions — and that reading his own corrected work revealed the grammar of the form to him "almost spontaneously." This account of learning through the discipline of the editorial process is itself a small epistemological document.

### *1.3 The Bīhani Kathā Theorist*

One of Munnaji's most significant contributions to Maithili literature is not just his creative practice but his theoretical work on the *bīhani kathā* (seed story) form. His extended essay "Bīhani Kathā — Mānakaraṇ O Tulnātmak Pakṣ"

(Seed Story — Standardization and Comparative Aspect), published in *Mokam Dis*, is the most sustained theoretical treatment of this Maithili-invented micro-fiction form in the language. He traces the history of Maithili narrative prose from its origins in Sanskrit adaptations through the colonial period's adoption of the English "short story" model, the problem of the conflation of "laghu kathā" (short story) with the even shorter form, and the 1995 Sahayatri Manch gathering at Lohna (Madhubani) at which, by collective consensus, the term *bīhani kathā* (proposed by Shri Raj) was adopted to distinguish Maithili's unique micro-fiction tradition from both the Hindi laghu kathā and the English flash fiction. Munnaji dedicates *Mokam Dis* "to Shri Raj, the creator of the word 'bīhani kathā'" — a formal act of scholarly attribution rare in Maithili creative writing.

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## PART II: PRIMARY WORKS — SYSTEMATIC DESCRIPTION AND ANALYSIS

### *2.1 Hum Puchhait Chhī (We Are Asking — A Series of Interviews, 2012)*

**Publication:** Shruti Prakashan, New Delhi. ISBN 978-93-80538-77-8. Price Rs. 100. First Edition 2012. Distributor: Pallavi Distributors, Nirmali, Supaul.

This volume of twenty-four interviews conducted by Munnaji with major figures of the Maithili literary world is arguably his most documentary and historically valuable work. The interviews span artists, writers, poets, fiction writers, playwrights, and critics:

2. Ravindra Kumar Das (painter, Maithili-Bhojpuri Academy)
3. Yogendra Prasad Yadav (linguist, Tribhuvan University, Nepal)
4. Govind Jha
5. Rajendra Bimal
6. Ram Bharos Kapari "Bhramar"
7. Ramesh Ranjan
8. Brishesh Chandra Lal
9. Dhirendra Premrishi
10. Analkant
11. Kumar Shailendra

12. Amarnath
13. Taranand Viyogi
14. Anmol Jha
15. Durganand Mandal
16. Mithilesh Kumar Jha
17. Bechan Thakur (the great Dalit playwright)
18. Dhirendra Kumar
19. Somdev (the democratic voice of Maithili fiction)
20. Ashok
21. Jyoti Sunit Chaudhary
22. Jagdish Prasad Mandal (Sahitya Akademi winner 2021)
23. Rajdeo Mandal (the “greatest living poet of Maithili” per Videha)
24. Devshankara Navin
25. Gajendra Thakur (editor, Videha)

The volume functions as an oral archive of the Maithili parallel tradition: the interviewees are almost without exception writers whom the Videha Parallel History identifies as belonging to the suppressed democratic canon — Bechan Thakur, Jagdish Prasad Mandal, Rajdeo Mandal, Somdev, Gajendra Thakur. Munnaji’s questions are probing, knowledgeable, and consistently focused on the relationship between literature and society: he asks Ravindra Kumar Das about the relationship between fine art and Mithila art, about institutional caste-politics in the Maithili-Bhojpuri Academy, about the absence of a Mithila art museum; he asks Yogendra Prasad Yadav (PhD in linguistics, Tribhuvan University) about Maithili syntax, Chomsky’s Government-Binding theory applied to Maithili, and multilingual education policy in Nepal.

The interview with Gajendra Thakur is particularly significant: here Munnaji interviews the very editor under whom he works, creating a dialogic self-positioning that places him simultaneously as journalist, literary collaborator, and chronicler.

### *2.2 Prateek (Symbol / Seed — Vihinikathā Collection, 2012)*

**Publication:** Shruti Prakashan. ISBN 978-93-80538-75-4. Price Rs. 200. First Edition 2012. Subtitled "Maithili Vihinikathā Saṅkalan" (Collection of Maithili Seed Stories). Preface by Gajendra Thakur (19 May 2012). Author's own preface: "Apan Kahab" (Our Own Statement).

The collection contains approximately sixty seed stories, arranged thematically and tonally. Key story titles from the table of contents reveal Munnaji's thematic range:

*Jamānā* (Era), *Nidhan* (Death), *Revāj* (Custom/Tradition), *Ārast* (Preparation), *Padauyā* (Neighbour), *Navayug* (New Age), *Ṭakaṭakī* (Staring), *Avāk* (Speechless), *Niyaṇṭraṇ* (Control), *Lilasā* (Desire), *Gahana* (Jewellery), *Khāndānī* (Hereditary/Family), *Dopingṭesṭ* (Doping Test), *Viṇimay* (Exchange), *Dānak Bausat* (Legacy of Gift), *Sejaūṭ* (Bed-making), *Junun* (Obsession), *Parmesar* (God), *Vijeta* (Victor), *Pajebā* (Anklet), *Hariyar Battī-Lāl Battī* (Green Light-Red Light), *Safāī* (Cleanliness), *Lagām* (Rein), *Premium*, *Mukiyaitī* (Headmanship), *Mul* (Root), *Vijātīya* (Alien/Outsider), *Kaunacar* (Corner), *Varūp O Sambhāvanā* (Form and Possibility), *Ātmānubhūti* (Self-realization), *Vikalp* (Option), *Janavāṇī* (People's Voice), *Rīlīph* (Relief), *Casmā* (Spectacles), *Jinagī* (Life), *Upahār* (Gift), *Sevak* (Servant), *Kaṭ* (Cut), *Tweṇṭī-Tweṇṭī* (Twenty-Twenty), *Okāti* (Capacity), *Jīvancakra* (Wheel of Life), *Bahurāṣṭrīya Kampanī* (Multinational Company), *Rak* (Blood), *Viśvāsghāt* (Betrayal), *Antarātmā* (Inner Soul), *Sāṛhe Ekaisam Sadī* (Twenty-first and a Half Century), *Kamniśā* (Kam Nisha / Intoxication), *Vdhyata* (Legitimacy), *Sarkārī Dalāl* (Government Broker), *Ṣaṛak-Chhāp* (Street-Level), *Jiyā jarae sagar rāt* (Let the heart burn all night), *Deś-Bhakti* (Patriotism), *Bhūkh* (Hunger), *Galati* (Mistake), *Deg* (Step), *Deha, Mon O Prem* (Body, Mind and Love), *Aguā* (Leader).

Gajendra Thakur's preface is an important critical document. He describes Munnaji's vihinikathā practice through the agricultural metaphor of seedlings (*bīhani*): Munnaji, he writes, scatters seeds more widely than his own field can absorb — like a neighbour whose seed surplus benefits the entire flood-zone community. He singles out several stories for specific notice: "Revāj," in which a widow asserts the right of her daughter to light the funeral pyre rather than her brother-in-law (a radical reversal of patriarchal inheritance); "Kamniśā" (with its potential to expand into a major novel on religious communal trauma); "Jiyā jarae sagar rāt" (addressing live-in relationships and sexual politics); "Diyād" (on caste-marked social behaviour visible only in small gestures); "Napanā"

(on the invisibility of women's domestic labour in census enumeration); and "Deha, Mon O Prem" (demonstrating how a *hāsya kaṇikā* (humorous anecdote) can be transformed into a genuine vihinikathā through tonal elevation). His overall judgment: the collection guarantees certainty (*niścit karait achhi*) for readers of the vihinikathā form.

Munnaji's own preface is a theoretical manifesto for the vihinikathā form. He distinguishes the vihinikathā from the Hindi laghu kathā, arguing that the Hindi form's adoption in Maithili was a case of blind imitation (*andhānukaraṇ*) of a form that Maithili already possessed natively under the name *kathā/galp*. The *bīhani kathā* — born in the 1995 Sahayatri Manch gathering — names what is specifically Maithili in micro-fiction: its seed-like brevity, its potential for organic expansion, its rooting in the specific ecology of Maithili social life.

### *2.3 Mājh Āṅgan Me Kaṭiāyal Chhī (Entangled in the Middle Courtyard — Ghazals and Rubā'ī, 2012)*

**Publication:** Shruti Prakashan. ISBN 978-93-80538-76-1. Price Rs. 200. Subtitle: "Anthology of Maithili Ghazal, Rubā'ī." First Edition 2012. Contents: 50 Ghazals + 11 Rubā'ī.

The title itself is a master stroke of Maithili ghazal poetics: *mājh āṅgan* (middle courtyard) is a specifically Maithili domestic spatial concept — the inner courtyard of the traditional Maithili house — while *kaṭiāyal chhī* (I am entangled) carries the emotional weight of ghazal's classical *giriftārī* (being caught, being ensnared). The phrase simultaneously evokes: the domestic space of Maithili women's lives, the entanglement of the poet in his own language and culture, and the amorous entanglement of ghazal's classical subject. This title-level semantic richness is characteristic of Munnaji's multi-layered compositional intelligence.

The three-part preface is an extended autobiography of a ghazal poet's formation, and simultaneously a history of the Maithili ghazal revival:

**Historical context:** The preface identifies 1990 as a pivotal year, when the joint ghazal anthology *Lāl Kilā Aur Lokved* (Red Fort and Folk-Knowledge), edited by Siyaram Jha "Saras," appeared. Munnaji's critique of the anthology's preface — which argued that only a practising ghazaleer can write ghazal criticism — is the starting point for his own counter-argument: that it took the *Ancinhar Ākhar* blog (2008), edited by Gajendra Thakur and Ashish Anchinhar, to finally provide Maithili ghazal with its first real grammar and critical vocabulary.

**The Ancinhar Ākhar significance:** Munnaji states that what a hundred years of ghazal writing in Maithili could not achieve — the provision of a systematic prosodic and critical framework — was accomplished in one year and five months by Gajendra Thakur. This is the Videha Parallel History claim at the level of poetic form: the digital counter-archive restored what institutional neglect had left undone.

**His own practice:** The fifty ghazals cover the full range of ghazal's traditional themes — love, loss, the pain of separation, social injustice, the nature of language itself — but consistently rooted in specifically Maithili imagery and idiom. The eleven rubā'ī (quatrains, the form associated with Omar Khayyam) extend his lyric range into a philosophical register.

### *2.4 Mokam Dis (Towards the Destination — Bīhani Kathā Collection)*

**Title:** *Mokam Dis* (Maithili bīhani kathā collection). Dedicated to Shri Raj, "creator of the word *bīhani kathā*."

This is Munnaji's most mature prose collection and the one most directly grounded in theoretical reflection. It contains 69 seed stories and opens with his extended critical essay on the standardization and comparative study of the bīhani kathā form. The story titles span a wide social geography: *Asarā* (Hope), *Sangave* (Together), *Chhucchhā Dulār* (Empty Affection), *Dihalagaṛī* (Daily Routine), *Upaṭṭī* (Uprooting), *Juṛabhan* (Connection), *Niṅghes* (Refusal), *Bakharā* (Share), *Aṅhariyā Ma* (Dark Mother), *Selphi* (Selfie), *Khaiych Dhān* (Harvested Rice), *Dāsīn* (Slave-woman), *Pratīk* (Symbol), *Sinehak Dhār* (Stream of Affection), *Ānchal* (The Hem), *Utthalū* (Uprising), *Bāṭ-Ghāṭ* (Roads and Crossings), *Ṣṛend* (Friend), *Parameśvar* (God), *Jiyā jarae sagar rāt* (Heart burning all night), *Sāṛhe Ekaisam Sadī* (Twenty-first and a Half Century), *Bhūkh* (Hunger), *Ṭelar* (Tailor), *Gaṇtantra* (Republic/Democracy), *Dāyitva* (Responsibility), *Canchhā* (Lunar), *Laul* (Wave), *Bīharaun* (Immigrant), *Saṅket* (Sign), *Targhuskī* (Undercutting), *Pustainī* (Ancestral), *Juānī* (Youth), *Atha* (Now), *Kharjitiyā* (Earning Woman), *Ehi Māṭik Raṅg* (The Colour of This Soil), *Zabiri* (Stubborn), *Ḥik* (Hiccup), *Adaun Saṅ* (From the Beginning), *Kaṭāh* (Pot), *Jhol* (Broth), *Paṭakaniyā* (Knockdown), *Pachatāvā* (Regret), *Karoṭ* (Turning), *Nivahatā* (Survival), *Rak* (Blood), *Vicaran* (Wandering), *Cunrī* (Headcloth), *Mukti* (Liberation), *Dareg* (Grief), *Riportāj* (Reportage), *Paraspara* (Mutual), *Ṭakaṭakī* (Stare), *Sutidhār* (Straight), *Vaidhavyatā* (Widowhood), *Kokhin* (Womb), *Vidhān* (Statute), *Mae banabāk haraṣ* (Joy of becoming a mother), *Bhār Ughait* (Lifting the Load), *Nimudhana Nai Chhī* (I Am Not Voiceless), *Ber Par* (On Time), *Vihān* (Dawn).

The story titles constitute a sociological map of contemporary Maithili life: technological change (*Selphi* — Selfie), agricultural ecology (*Khaichk Dhān*), reproductive politics (*Kokhin* — Womb; *Mae banabāk haraṣ* — Joy of becoming a mother), labour (*Kharjitiyā* — earning woman; *Bhār Ughait* — lifting the load), democratic politics (*Gaṇtantra* — Republic), violence and resistance (*Zabiri* — Stubborn; *Nimudhana Nai Chhī* — I Am Not Voiceless). The theoretical essay which opens the collection frames all of this within a genealogy of the vihinikathā form that connects Maithili micro-fiction to its Sanskrit roots through Chanda Jha's translation of Vidyapati's *Puruṣa Parīkṣā*, through the encounter with Western short fiction via Bengali, and forward to the 1995 formal coinage of the form's name.

### *2.5 Ghah: Maithili Haiku Tāṅkāk Saṅgor (Grass: A Collection of Maithili Haiku and Tanka, 2012)*

This collection of Maithili haiku and tanka is written in Devanagari/Kaithi script and represents Munnaji's contribution to one of the most globally resonant short poetic forms. The title *Ghah* (Grass) is itself a haiku-worthy word: its monosyllabic compression, its images of fragility and persistence, its democratic refusal of floral grandeur in favour of the humble blade that survives all seasons.

The preface is a substantial historical essay on the haiku tradition: Munnaji traces the form from its Japanese origins in Matsuo Bashō (1644–1694), through hokku and the development of haiku proper, through the tanka form (31 syllables in 5-7-5-7-7 pattern), through Rabindranath Tagore's 1919 return from Japan with two haiku which he translated into Bengali — "the creator of haiku was Bashō." He then turns to Maithili: he identifies a persistent indifference among Maithili writers to the haiku form, attributing it partly to the weight of the Sanskrit/classical tradition and partly to the dominance of narrative prose genres in contemporary Maithili writing. He records his own first Maithili haiku's publication (10 July 1995, Dainik Aaj, Patna), his earlier Hindi haiku practice, and his decision to commit exclusively to Maithili haiku as an act of linguistic loyalty. The collection — he hopes — will be the first independent Maithili haiku-tanka anthology in Tirhuta/Devanagari script, filling the void that the indifference of Maithili literary culture had left.

The haiku themselves address themes characteristic of both the Japanese form and Maithili social life: water scarcity, governance failure, the technological bewilderment of the elderly, adolescent aspiration, rural poverty.

### *2.6 Khurluchhī (Children's Poetry Collection, 2012)*

This collection of children's poetry (*bāl kavitā*) and children's ghazals (*bāl ghazal*) is a distinctive contribution to a genre — Maithili children's literature — that the preface notes was historically stunted by the dominance of classical Sanskrit models and by adults writing for children without genuinely inhabiting a child's mental universe. The preface is candid about the institutional dynamics: the Sahitya Akademi's declaration of a children's literature prize stimulated a rush of Maithili children's writing, but the first prize went to a translation rather than an original work — reinforcing the pattern of institutional reward for secondary rather than primary creative labor.

The collection contains twenty-two poems and twelve bāl ghazals. Poem titles: *Pāni Bacāo* (Save Water), *Totārāme* (Parakeet Rama), *Tūr* (Drum), *Rangabandhan* (Festival of Colours), *Beimān* (Dishonest One), *Bāsā* (Home), *Khelkud* (Play), *Ekratta Batti* (One Thread of Light), *Cānd-Tārā* (Moon-Stars), *Bāgh* (Tiger), *Barkhā* (Rain), *Āmak Gacc* (The Mango Tree), *Bidesi Cīj* (Foreign Things), *Bāp-Betā* (Father-Son), *Matak Kokhase* (From Mother's Womb), *Nīk Baci* (Good Child), *Bhorukbā* (Dawn), *Hamar Des* (My Country), *Bijulikā* (Lightning), *Kharicā* (Scratch), *Kariyā Bādal* (Black Cloud), *Āgā Gacc* (Come Trees). The twelve bāl ghazals constitute a formal innovation — applying the adult ghazal's prosodic discipline to children's subject matter, a pedagogically ambitious project that simultaneously teaches children formal prosody and gives them access to the emotional complexity of the ghazal register.

### *2.7 Tīntā Bāl Nāṭak (Three Children's Plays, 2012)*

The three plays are: *Parī Nagar* (Fairy City), *Gāch Bacāo* (Save the Trees), and *Baijū Bāvarā* (the legendary musician). All are written in accessible Maithili prose suitable for school performance. The dramatis personae of *Parī Nagar* include a Fairy Queen (Parīrānī), a Doorkeeper, a Landlord/Landlady, four prince-friends (Jay, Vijay, Ajay, Sanjay), and supporting characters — a universe of inter-generational conflict, adventure, and moral testing. *Gāch Bacāo* is an environmental play centred on tree-preservation. *Baijū Bāvarā* draws on the legendary musician Baiju Bawra's story, bringing classical Indian musical tradition into a children's performance format.

## PART III: CRITICAL APPRECIATION THROUGH MULTIPLE FRAMEWORKS

### *3.1 Genre Theory and Munnaji's Multi-Generic Achievement*

What is immediately striking about Munnaji's output — seven distinct books published in a single year (2012) across at least six different genres — is its radical multi-genericity. Genre theory (from Aristotle's *Poetics* through Mikhail Bakhtin's theory of speech genres to Tzvetan Todorov's structural genre theory and Jacques Derrida's "law of genre") typically emphasizes that literary mastery involves the sustained inhabitation of a single form. Munnaji explicitly challenges this assumption.

His theoretical writing on the bīhani kathā shows that this multi-generic practice is not opportunistic diversity but principled intermediality: he understands genres as existing in dialogue and mutual transformation — the haiku's compression informs the seed story; the ghazal's emotional architecture informs the interview's mode of address; the children's play's performance logic connects back to the oral culture of village manch-sancālan that first formed him. In Bakhtinian terms, Munnaji's literary production is profoundly *dialogic*: each genre speaks to and through the others.

### *3.2 Indian Rasa-Dhvani Aesthetics*

Within the framework of Bharata's *Nāṭyaśāstra* and Ānandavardhana's *Dhvanyāloka*, Munnaji's bīhani kathā works primarily through the rasa of *karuṇa* (pathos/compassion) and *bībhatsa* (disgust/horror at social violence), frequently with an undercurrent of *hāsya* (comedy/satire) that sharpens rather than dissolves the dominant emotional tone. The story "Revāj" (Custom) is paradigmatic: the surface narrative concerns a widow asserting her daughter's right to light the funeral pyre. The *vibhāva* (excitant) is the accumulated weight of patriarchal custom; the *anubhāva* (ensuant) is the widow's quiet, firm assertion; the *sthāyibhāva* (stable emotion) is karuṇa — but the dhvani (resonance) extends far beyond this particular funeral to the entire structure of property and inheritance rights that caste-patriarchy enforces over women's bodies and domestic spaces.

Ānandavardhana's distinction between *abhidhā-mūla dhvani* (resonance based on primary meaning), *lakṣaṇā-mūla dhvani* (resonance based on secondary/indicated meaning), and *vyañjanā-mūla dhvani* (resonance based on suggestive power) applies precisely to Munnaji's micro-fiction. In "Napanā"

(Measurement/Enumeration), the surface meaning — the government census does not count women's domestic labour — triggers a lakṣaṇā-mūla dhvani that gestures toward the entire devaluation of reproductive labour in capitalism; the vyañjanā-mūla dhvani opens onto the deepest question of who counts as a citizen and what counts as work.

Abhinavagupta's doctrine of *sādhāraṇīkaraṇa* (universalization of particular experience through aesthetic identification) is central to understanding why Munnaji's seed stories — despite their micro-scale — achieve genuine literary resonance. Because they are not about named individuals but about types and situations recognizable to all Maithili readers, the reader's aesthetic identification (*sāmājikatā*) is immediate and complete. The story "Bhūkh" (Hunger) does not need to name its characters because hunger is universal; the Maithili-specific details (*Koshi flood plain*, Supaul's seasonal devastation) anchor the universal in the particular without restricting it.

For the ghazals, the appropriate Indian aesthetic framework is the theory of *vakrokti* (oblique expression) developed by Kuntaka in the *Vakroktijīvita* (c. 10th century CE). The ghazal's constitutive form — the couplet (*śer*) in which each *miṣrā* (hemistich) must stand independently while also contributing to the whole — is structurally a machine for generating *vakrokti*: the oblique, figurative, compressed expression that carries meaning through indirection rather than statement. Munnaji's title *Mājh Āṅgan Me Kaṭiāyal Chhī* is itself a perfect vakrokti: the domestic spatial image becomes a figure for existential and emotional entanglement.

### *3.3 The Haiku: Wabi-Sabi and Maithili Ecological Consciousness*

The haiku tradition originates in the Japanese aesthetic concepts of *wabi* (austere simplicity), *sabi* (the beauty of impermanence and loneliness), and *yūgen* (mysterious grace). Munnaji's *Ghah* brings these aesthetic values into dialogue with Maithili ecological consciousness — the Koshi flood plain's ecology of abundance and devastation, the seasonal rhythms of rice cultivation, the slow ecological crisis documented also in Dinesh Kumar Mishra's flood studies (a key figure in the Videha Parallel History). His haiku on water conservation (*Pāni Bacāo* in the children's collection) speaks to an ecological emergency that has afflicted the Koshi region since the 1954 and 1987 floods. The apparent lightness of haiku — its commitment to the precise observation of a single moment — paradoxically allows it to carry the weight of historical and ecological crisis more effectively than extended argumentative prose.

The classical haiku's *kireji* (cutting word) — the point of internal tension that divides the haiku into two semantically charged halves — finds its Maithili equivalent in the compression of natural image against social reality. This is the structural correlate of the bīhani kathā's climactic irony: both forms work through the productive collision of two incommensurable realities held together in minimal space.

### *3.4 Western Literary Theory*

#### 3.4.1 Russian Formalism and the Concept of Ostranenie

Viktor Shklovsky's concept of *ostranenie* (defamiliarization, *Theory of Prose*, 1925) — the idea that great literature makes the familiar seem strange, breaking through the automatism of habitual perception — is central to understanding the aesthetic effect of Munnaji's micro-fiction. The story "Selphi" (Selfie) defamiliarizes the ubiquitous smartphone gesture by placing it in a Maithili village context where its meaning is radically unstable. "Gaṇtantra" (Republic/Democracy) defamiliarizes the word itself — the abstraction of democratic self-governance — by juxtaposing it with a concrete Maithili social reality where the *gaṇ* (people) are absent from *tantra* (governance). Shklovsky's claim that the technique of art is to make objects "unfamiliar" and to "increase the difficulty and length of perception" is accomplished in Munnaji's work not through structural difficulty but through the strategic placement of a single ironic detail that forces the reader to re-see what they thought they already understood.

#### 3.4.2 Post-Colonial Theory: Bhabha's Third Space

Homi Bhabha's concept of the *Third Space* (*The Location of Culture*, 1994) — the hybrid space of cultural negotiation in which colonial and colonial-subject meanings are rewritten — describes Munnaji's literary positioning precisely. He writes in Maithili, a language classified as a "dialect of Hindi" by the colonial census apparatus despite its distinct literary history. He employs forms (haiku, ghazal, rubā'ī) that originate in Japanese and Arabic/Persian traditions and have been absorbed into the Indian literary system through the mediation of Hindi and Urdu. His children's plays adapt classical mythological material (*Baijū Bāvarā*) for contemporary school performance. Each of these acts of cultural translation — form, language, subject matter — occupies what Bhabha calls the Third Space: neither purely "indigenous" Maithili tradition nor simply imitative of Hindi or English models, but a creative hybrid that rewrites both.

The interview collection *Hum Puchhait Chhī* is itself a Third Space performance: Munnaji, as interviewer, occupies a position that is simultaneously journalistic (a Western-origin form), literary-critical (operating within the Maithili tradition of *samālochanā*), and oral-performative (connected to the village *manch* tradition that first formed him).

### 3.4.3 Feminist Criticism: Cixous, Kristeva, and the Woman's Voice in Munnaji's Prose

While Munnaji is a male writer, several of his most powerful seed stories occupy the perspective of women navigating patriarchal constraint: the widow asserting funeral rights ("Revāj"), the woman whose domestic labour goes uncounted ("Napanā"), the mother asserting reproductive autonomy ("Kokhin"), the woman who supports the household through her own earnings ("Kharjitiyā"). Hélène Cixous's concept of *écriture féminine* — writing that refuses the binary logic of patriarchal language and speaks instead from the body, from affect, from the non-hierarchical — finds a partial correlate in Munnaji's seed stories' refusal of the linear narrative that positions women as passive objects. Each of these stories gives women the final word, the final gesture, the structural authority of the bīhani's climactic irony.

Julia Kristeva's distinction between the *semiotic* (pre-linguistic, rhythmic, bodily) and the *symbolic* (paternal law, the social-linguistic order) helps explain the power of Munnaji's children's literature: the children's poems and plays operate in the semiotic register — rhythmic, playful, sound-oriented — while simultaneously encoding symbolic content (environmental consciousness, democratic values, the importance of education) through a form that children absorb unconsciously.

### 3.4.4 Cultural Materialism and Raymond Williams

Raymond Williams's concept of *structures of feeling* (*Marxism and Literature*, 1977) — the pre-ideological, emergent dimension of social experience that literature captures before ideology has codified it — is illuminated by Munnaji's story "Selphi": the smartphone selfie in a Maithili village is precisely an emergent cultural practice whose social meaning has not yet crystallized into ideology. Munnaji's micro-fiction captures this emergent structure of feeling — the confusion, desire, and disorientation of rapid technological change in a traditional community — before any systematic analysis has formalized it. This is the specific value of micro-fiction as a form: its compression allows it to be faster than the social-science apparatus.

Williams's *hegemony* concept — the way dominant cultural forms maintain themselves not through overt coercion but through the naturalization of their assumptions — is directly pertinent to the Videha Parallel History context within which Munnaji writes. The hegemony of the Sahitya Akademi's upper-caste Maithili canon naturalized its own selectivity: by defining the "good" in Maithili literature in ways that systematically excluded lower-caste, female, Dalit, and Nepal-side voices, it made its exclusions seem like neutral aesthetic judgments. Munnaji's multi-generic practice — spanning a range of forms that the Sahitya Akademi's prize categories barely acknowledge — is a form of counter-hegemonic cultural production.

## *3.5 The Videha Parallel History Framework*

### 3.5.1 Munnaji's Position in the Parallel Tradition

The Videha masthead identifies Munnaji (Manoj Kumar Karna) as a *Sahāyak Sampādak* (Assistant Editor) of *Videha: Pratham Maithili Pāksik Ī-Patrikā*, alongside other key figures of the democratic counter-canon. This institutional positioning is not incidental: the Videha Parallel History identifies the mainstream Maithili literary establishment as systematically excluding the democratic tradition, and Munnaji's role as editor actively constructs the alternative archive.

His interview book *Hum Puchhait Chhī* is a direct contribution to the Parallel History project: by recording the voices of Bechan Thakur, Jagdish Prasad Mandal, Rajdeo Mandal, Somdev, and Gajendra Thakur — the writers whom the Parallel History identifies as the truly great contemporary Maithili voices — Munnaji creates primary documentary evidence for the counter-canonical record. The oral archive of these interviews constitutes, in the Videha framework's terms, a "living parallel institution."

### 3.5.2 The Bīhani Kathā as Parallel Form

Munnaji's theoretical and creative investment in the *bīhani kathā* is itself a Parallel History act: the form, born in 1995 in Lohna (Madhubani) through collective democratic process, is not a product of institutional patronage, academic curricula, or Sahitya Akademi recognition, but of grassroots literary community building. That its name was proposed by a relatively unknown writer (Shri Raj) and adopted by consensus — that Munnaji formally dedicates a collection to that writer as the "creator" of the form's name — is a model of

democratic literary production that the Parallel History holds up against the celebrity-and-cronyism model of institutional canon formation.

The Videha Parallel History explicitly documents the bīhani kathā's development and revival: Gajendra Thakur's preface to *Prateek* credits Munnaji as the form's most committed practitioner ("*Munnājī vihinikathā lel samarpita chhi*" — Munnaji is devoted to the vihinikathā). This formal recognition within the Videha institution constitutes Munnaji's official enshrinement in the parallel canon.

### 3.5.3 The Haiku and the Ancinhar Ākhar Movement

Munnaji's haiku collection and ghazal collection are both explicitly connected to the *Ancinhar Ākhar* (Uncelebrated Letters) movement — the Videha-affiliated Maithili ghazal reform movement led by Ashish Anchinhar. His prefaces credit Ashish Anchinhar with the sustained critical engagement that brought his ghazals to publishable quality. The *Ancinhar Ākhar* blog, launched 2008, is identified in the Videha Parallel History (Part 4) as the movement that revitalized Maithili ghazal. Munnaji's collections are direct products of this revitalization.

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## *3.6 Navya-Nyāya Epistemology: Gaṅgeśa's Framework Applied*

### 3.6.1 Vihinikathā and the Logic of the Seed

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's *Tattvacintāmaṇi* (c. 1325 CE) develops the most sophisticated logical vocabulary in Indian philosophical history. Three of his key analytical tools — *pakṣa* (the locus), *sādhya* (the property to be established), and *vyāpti* (invariable concomitance) — provide a precise structural analysis of how Munnaji's seed stories generate meaning.

The vihinikathā works through an inferential structure that Navya-Nyāya can formalize. Take "Revāj" (Custom/Tradition): the *pakṣa* (locus) is this particular funeral. The *sādhya* (thing to be proved) is the daughter's right to light the pyre. The *hetu* (reason/middle term) is "her father died in the absence of a son." The *vyāpti* (invariable concomitance) deployed by the story is: wherever a woman asserts her right in the face of patriarchal custom, that assertion demands recognition as legitimate. The story's *dhvani* (resonance) extends the inference from this particular *pakṣa* to all situations where custom (*revāj*) is used to deny women their legal and moral rights.

This inferential structure — the movement from the particular (seed/bīhani) to the universal (the general social claim) through a *vyāpti* that is felt rather than stated — is precisely what Munnaji's preface describes when he says the vihinikathā is a *bīā* (seed) from which larger narratives can grow. The seed story does not state its *sādhya* explicitly; it establishes the *vyāpti* through narrative compression, leaving the reader to complete the inference. This is the aesthetic correlate of Navya-Nyāya's *anumāna pramāṇa* (inferential cognition as valid knowledge).

### 3.6.2 Pramāṇa Analysis of the Interview as Genre

Munnaji's interview collection *Hum Puchhait Chhī* can be analyzed through Navya-Nyāya's *śabdapramāṇa* (verbal testimony as valid knowledge). For an interview to function as *āptavākya* (trustworthy testimony), the interviewer must be *āpta* (reliable, competent) and the interviewee must be *āpta* in their domain of expertise. Munnaji establishes his *āptatā* (reliability) through his demonstrated knowledge of Maithili literature and his insider position within the Videha community; the interviewees' authority is established by their literary achievements and institutional positions. The result is a form of *śabdapramāṇa* that constitutes genuine knowledge: the interviews produce valid cognition (*pramā*) about the state of Maithili literature that could not be obtained by any other *pramāṇa* (neither perception nor inference alone).

### 3.6.3 The Haiku and Navya-Nyāya's Theory of Absence (Abhāva)

Navya-Nyāya's analysis of *abhāva* (absence) as a positive epistemological category — an absence is not merely the negation of presence but is itself cognizable and real — maps onto the haiku's fundamental structural principle. The haiku works through what it does not say: the *kireji*'s cut creates a productive *abhāva* — the absence of explicit connection between the two halves generates the semantic work of the poem. Munnaji's *Ghah* collection's title captures this: grass (*ghah*) is the *abhāva* of the remarkable — the un-noticed, the present-by-absence, the overlooked vitality that persists precisely where no one thinks to look.

Gaṅgeśa's *prāgabhāva* (prior absence, the absence before an event occurs) and *dhvaṁsābhāva* (posterior absence, the absence after something ceases) together describe the temporal structure of haiku consciousness: every haiku moment is framed by the prior absence of the moment (before it was noticed, it was nothing) and the posterior absence (after the poem ends, the moment is

gone again). The haiku is the bridge between these two absences — a *pratiyogitā* (counter-relatum) that makes the absent moment positively present.

### 3.6.4 The Suppressed Gaṅgeśa and Munnaji's Social Position

The Videha Parallel History's recovery of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's suppressed inter-caste origins — born to a *Charmkarini* (leather-tanning caste) mother, a fact concealed by upper-caste historians — creates a structural parallel with Munnaji's own position. Munnaji writes from Nirmali, Supaul: a non-metropolitan location in the Koshi flood zone, part of the historically marginalized eastern reaches of Mithila. His surname Karna connects him to the Mahabharata's greatest victim of caste injustice. His literary community — the Videha circle, the Pallavi Distributors network, the Sahayatri Manch — is deliberately counter-institutional, self-organized, cooperative.

Gaṅgeśa's *Tattvacintāmaṇi* arose from this same Mithila — and Gaṅgeśa's radical epistemological project (subjecting every claim to rigorous logical analysis, refusing to accept inherited authority without reasoned examination) is the philosophical foundation for the Videha movement's own refusal to accept the Sahitya Akademi's authority. Munnaji's practical democratic epistemology — interviewing writers, collecting their testimonies, insisting on the validity of their experience — mirrors Gaṅgeśa's project at the level of cultural documentation rather than formal logic.

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## PART IV: STRUCTURAL AND FORMAL ANALYSIS

### *4.1 The Architecture of the Seed Story*

Munnaji's most distinctive formal innovation is his mastery of what he calls the *bīhani kathā*'s structural grammar. His theoretical essay in *Mokam Dis* describes this grammar in terms of the agricultural metaphor: like the seed (*bīhani*), the micro-fiction must contain within its compressed form the full genetic potential of a larger narrative, while being capable of independent germination. The formal requirements are: extreme brevity (typically one to three paragraphs); a single narrative turn or ironic revelation; characters who are types rather than individuals; and a final image or gesture that releases the story's dhvani.

Structurally, each bīhani kathā follows what can be described as a Navya-Nyāya inferential schema: a *uddeśya* (subject, what the story is about)

established in the opening line; a middle section of *dharma* (properties, circumstances) established through compressed narration; and a final line that performs the *pratyaya* (recognition, the moment of valid cognition) in which the reader completes the inferential process the story has set in motion.

### *4.2 The Ghazal's Prosodic Discipline*

Munnaji's forty-four complete ghazals and some with only four couplets (as he honestly acknowledges in his preface, noting this is a technical deficiency since proper ghazals require at least five couplets) reflect a poet working through the discipline of a demanding form. The Maithili ghazal's prosodic requirements — *radīf* (refrain), *qāfiyā* (rhyme scheme), *maṭla'* (opening couplet, both hemistichs rhyming with the radīf), *maqṭa'* (closing couplet, traditionally containing the poet's name or pen name) — are rigorously observed in Munnaji's mature ghazals. His twelve rubā'ī (quatrains) follow the *AABA* rhyme scheme of the classical Omar Khayyamian rubā'ī form.

### *4.3 The Children's Literature: Formal Pedagogy*

The *Khurluchhī* collection's formal innovation — the bāl ghazal (children's ghazal) — is pedagogically significant. By applying ghazal's formal discipline to children's subject matter, Munnaji creates a form that initiates young Maithili readers into poetic prosody while entertaining them. The word *khurluchhī* itself is an onomatopoeic Maithili term for the playful scratching or tickling sensation — a title that announces the collection's register: light, tactile, playful, intimate.

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## PART V: ASSESSMENT AND CONCLUSION

### *5.1 Munnaji's Achievement: A Synthesis*

Munnaji (Manoj Kumar Karna) represents, within the Videha Parallel tradition of Maithili literature, a writer of unusual breadth and democratic commitment. In a single year of publication (2012), he produced:

- A landmark collection of literary interviews that constitutes an oral archive of the Maithili parallel tradition
- Two collections of bīhani kathā that advance both the theory and practice of Maithili micro-fiction

- A ghazal collection that embodies the *Ancinhar Ākhar* movement's formal renewal
- A haiku-tanka collection that establishes Maithili's independent relationship to a globally resonant form
- A children's poetry collection that innovates the *bāl ghazal* form
- A children's drama collection that brings mythological and environmental themes to school performance

This output places Munnaji in a very small class of contemporary Maithili writers who have genuinely expanded the formal repertoire of the language while simultaneously deepening its social and political engagement.

### *5.2 Convergence of Frameworks*

The critical convergence across all our analytical frameworks is consistent:

- **Indian rasa-dhvani aesthetics** identifies karuṇa and hāsya as the dominant rasas in the fiction, dhvani as the primary mode of semantic operation in both the stories and the ghazals, and vakrokti as the defining formal principle of the ghazal collection.
- **Western formalism** (Shklovsky) identifies ostranenie as the consistent aesthetic strategy in the micro-fiction; **genre theory** (Bakhtin) reveals the dialogic relationship between Munnaji's multiple genres; **feminist criticism** finds in his prose a consistent centering of women's voices and perspectives; **cultural materialism** (Williams) identifies his work as capturing emergent structures of feeling in contemporary Maithili society.
- **The Videha Parallel History framework** situates Munnaji as one of the core institutional figures of the democratic counter-canon — editor, interviewer, theorist, multi-genre practitioner — whose work constitutes both a critical archive and a creative counter-monument to the Sahitya Akademi mainstream.
- **Navya-Nyāya epistemology** (Gaṅgeśa) provides the formal vocabulary to show how the bīhani kathā works through *anumāna* (inferential cognition), how the haiku works through *abhāva* (productive absence), and how the interview collection functions as *śabdapramāṇa* (valid verbal testimony) — making visible the epistemological architecture underlying Munnaji's apparently intuitive literary practice.

### *5.3 Significance*

Munnaji's significance for Maithili literature lies not only in his individual works but in the institutional and theoretical work they embody. He is at once a creative practitioner and a systematic theorist; a collector of others' voices and a creator of his own; a writer rooted in the Koshi flood plain of Supaul and a practitioner of globally resonant forms (haiku, ghazal, rubā'ī). The sum of his work is a portrait of Maithili literary culture at the moment of its digital-democratic revival — caught, like his title says, *entangled in the middle courtyard* of its own historical transformation.

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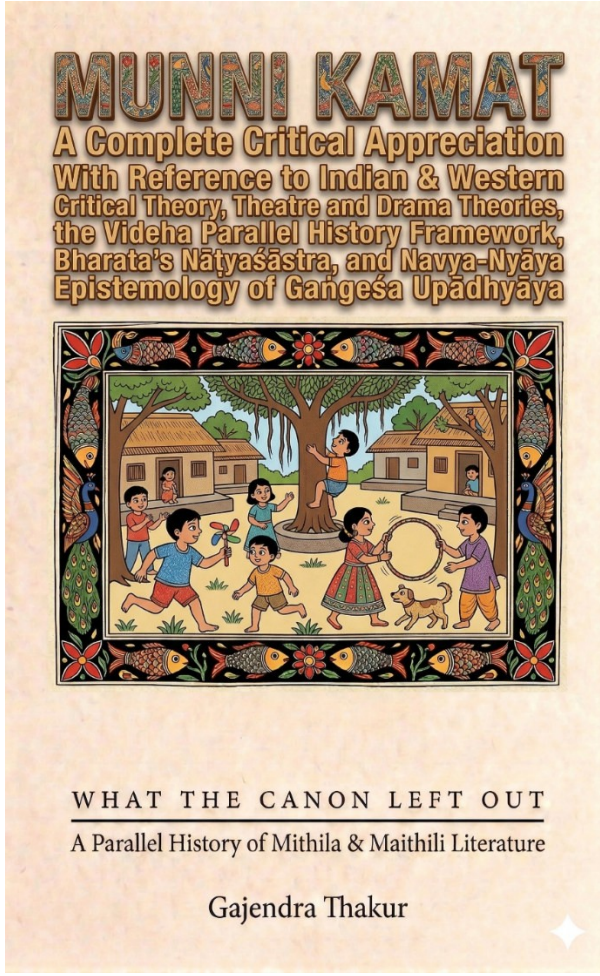
*This research report forms part of the Videha Parallel History series on Maithili literature. All quotations from the primary texts are the author’s translations from the Maithili originals.*

**LESSON 047 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**




# MUNNI KAMAT

*A Complete Critical Appreciation*

*With Reference to Indian & Western Critical Theory, Theatre and Drama Theories,*

*the Videha Parallel History Framework, Bharata's Nāṭyaśāstra,*

*and Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya*

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## Abstract

This monograph presents a complete critical appreciation of the literary works of Munni Kamat (मुन्नी कामत), a contemporary Maithili poet, playwright, prose writer, and novelist whose creative output spans poetry, seed stories (Bīhani Kathā), one-act plays, and the novel form. Her principal published works examined here are: Sukhal Man Tarsal Āṃkhi (2014, revised 2017), a tripartite volume of poems, seed stories, and one-act plays; Antatah (2019), a Maithili poetry collection; Munni Kamat Chukka (a critical anthology); Māṭik Suwas (2023), her debut Maithili novel; and SUKHAL MAN TARSAL AAKHI (third edition). Born in the culturally rich heartland of Mithila, between the rivers Kamala and Kosi, Kamat writes in Maithili — a language of seventy-five million speakers, constitutionally recognised since 2003 — and belongs to the 'parallel tradition' documented and promoted by the Videha eJournal.

This study applies a multi-layered critical framework encompassing: (i) Indian classical aesthetic theory — Bharata's Nāṭyaśāstra, Rasa-Dhvani aesthetics (Ānandavardhana, Abhinavagupta), Vakrokti (Kuntaka), and Alaṃkāra theory; (ii) Western literary and dramatic theory — Aristotelian poetics, Brechtian epic theatre, feminist criticism (Simone de Beauvoir, Elaine Showalter), postcolonial theory (Spivak, Bhabha), and New Historicism; (iii) Navya-Nyāya epistemological methodology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (Tattvacintāmaṇi); (iv) the Videha Parallel History Framework (Gajendra Thakur); and (v) theatre and drama theories from both Sanskrit and modern traditions. The study argues that Kamat's work constitutes a vital democratic, feminist, and social-realist intervention in Maithili literature — one that has been systematically marginalised by mainstream institutional recognition.

# I. Bio-Bibliographic Introduction: Munni Kamat in Context

## 1.1 Life and Background

Munni Kamat (मुन्नी कामत) is a contemporary Maithili woman writer born in the village region between the rivers Kamala and Kosi — the ancient heartland of Mithila, historically coterminous with the kingdom of Videha. She spent her formative years as a student with the original family name Munni Verma, a name by which she was known in Hindi literary circles, before adopting the pen name and identity of 'Munni Kamat' as her primary literary identity. She is described in Antatah's preface as residing in Patna, having moved from the village to the city while retaining a profound attachment to the rural landscape of Mithila.

As a student, she was noted for her exceptional academic dedication — studying 16-18 hours a day — and for her fluency in public speaking and debate. The preface to Antatah records her as a woman who has chosen to claim her rights, to stand as a lone figure against the world, to place the human and society in the dock of her fearless writing, and who — despite hunger and pain — continues to fight with her pen as her only weapon. This biographical portrait is not merely personal: it is the animating force behind her literary project.

Geographically and culturally, Kamat belongs to the Mithila that lies between the Kamala and Kosi rivers — a landscape that flows between drought and flood, between the mythological Sita and the socio-political present. This landscape haunts her poetry and drama as a recurring symbol of both nurture and precarity.

## 1.2 Published Works: A Bibliographic Survey

| | |
|---|---|
| **Title** | Sukhal Man Tarsal Āṃkhi (सुखल मन तरसल आँखि) |
| **Language** | Maithili |
| **Genre** | Poems, Seed Stories (Bīhani Kathā), One-act Plays |

| | |
|---|---|
| | (Ekaṅkī-Nāṭak) |
| **Publisher** | Shruti Prakashan, New Delhi |
| **First Edition** | 2014 |
| **Second Edition** | 2017 (revised) |
| **Significance** | First published tripartite collection; foundational text |

| | |
|---|---|
| **Title** | Antatah (अन्ततः) |
| **Language** | Maithili |
| **Genre** | Poetry Collection |
| **Publisher** | Gita-Shri Prakashan, Patna |
| **Edition** | First Edition: 10 July 2019 |
| **Dedication** | Dedicated to revered mentor Dr. Shiv Kumarji |
| **Significance** | Second standalone poetry collection; deepening lyrical voice |

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| **Title** | Māṭik Suwas (माटिक सुवास) |
| **Language** | Maithili |
| **Genre** | Novel |
| **Publisher** | Navarambh Prakashan (navarambh.com) |
| **Edition** | First Edition: 2023 |
| **Significance** | Kamat's first novel; marks transition to long-form prose fiction |

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|---|---|
| **Title** | Munni Kamat Chukka |
| **Language** | Maithili |
| **Genre** | Critical/Selected anthology |
| **Note** | Extended critical compendium of her work |

### 1.3 Archival and Digital Presence

Munni Kamat's work is archived and promoted through the Videha eJournal (ISSN 2229-547X, www.videha.co.in), the first Maithili fortnightly e-journal, founded and edited by Gajendra Thakur. Videha has been central to the digitisation, promotion, and critical recovery of parallel-tradition Maithili literature since 2004. Kamat is listed among the 'parallel women tradition' voices, alongside Vibha Rani, Kamini Kamayani, Susmita Pathak, Premlata Mishra Prem, and Panna Jha — writers whose work has been systematically excluded from the Sahitya Akademi mainstream while flourishing in the democratic digital space of Videha.

The Wikidata entry for Munni Kamat (Q134972282) records her occupation as 'writer' and 'poet,' working in the Maithili language — confirming her recognition at the international bibliographic level. Her physical books have been distributed through Pallavi Distributors (Supaul) and Navarambh Prakashan, serving the Maithili diaspora across India and beyond.

## II. Textual Analysis: Major Works and Themes

### 2.1 Poetry: Sukhal Man Tarsal Āṃkhi and Antatah

#### *2.1.1 The Title as Poetic Programme*

The title Sukhal Man Tarsal Āṃkhi — literally 'Dry Heart, Longing Eyes' — is itself a compressed lyric, announcing the central tension of Kamat's poetic universe: between emotional aridity (the desiccated, suppressed inner world of women, the poor, the marginalised) and the yearning eye that sees and longs for

justice, beauty, and recognition. The title operates as a Dhvani (resonance) that pervades the entire collection.

The title Antatah — meaning 'ultimately' or 'in the end' — signals a philosophical movement toward resolution, reckoning, or conclusion. If Sukhal Man Tarsal Āṃkhi captures the condition, Antatah gestures toward a reckoning with it. Together, the two titles enact a dialectical movement that is central to Kamat's poetic method.

### *2.1.2 Poems of Social Protest and Gender Critique*

The opening poem of the collection addresses the fate of daughters in patriarchal Mithila society. The poem 'Samarpit hoit beti' ('Being Offered Up as a Daughter') traces the arc of a woman's life from birth — when a lamp is extinguished — through socialization as a 'burden of society' and 'father's turban' to marriage and self-sacrifice:

*"Ek janam bital, / dosar janam la taiiyar bha gel / Kekaro nai kichhu kahlak / Hari dam samarpit hot gael / Juban rahi to bejuban bani / Sabh dukh sahaait gael."* **— Sukhal Man Tarsal Āṃkhi, poem 'Samarpit hoit beti'**

This poem demonstrates Kamat's engagement with feminist themes through a restrained, lyrical mode rather than polemical declaration — making the critique all the more devastating. The poem enacts what Elaine Showalter calls 'the female tradition' — writing from within experience rather than from outside theory.

The poem 'Manukh ka sauda' ('The Trading of Humans') addresses the dowry system with bitter irony, placing human beings on the market alongside commodities:

*"Lakh-do-lakh / Panch-panch lakh / par bat hoi chhai / Timan-tarkari jak / Manukho ab sauda hoi chhai."* **— Sukhal Man Tarsal Āṃkhi, 'Manukh ka sauda'**

In Naṭyaśāstra terms, this poem activates the Raudra Rasa (the sentiment of fury) and Bībhatsa Rasa (disgust), but through a distanced, ironic register that Abhinavagupta might recognise as the 'relishing' (āsvādana) of a generalised emotional state rather than direct personal outrage. In Western terms, the poem employs what Brecht would call Verfremdungseffekt — alienation through matter-of-fact enumeration of prices — to produce critical consciousness rather than cathartic identification.

### *2.1.3 Nature Poetry and Landscape of Mithila*

A significant strand of Kamat's poetry involves the landscape and ecology of Mithila — rivers, fields, rain, drought. The recurring imagery of the dried/thirsty eye and dry heart maps onto the ecological reality of the Kosi-Kamala region, where water is simultaneously life and destruction. The preface to Antatah makes explicit the connection: 'Just as in the monsoon season, the Bhoothahi river flows with speed — but after a few days becomes dry — so Munni does not stop.'

This ecological consciousness places Kamat within a long tradition of Maithili nature poetry, while simultaneously giving it contemporary urgency. The Nāṭyaśāstra's concept of Vibhāva (excitants or determinants of rasa) is operative here: the natural landscape functions as an ālambana-vibhāva (permanent excitant) for the emotional states of longing, sorrow, and hope that pervade the poems.

### *2.1.4 Structure and Form in the Poetry*

Kamat writes primarily in the conversational, direct register of modern Maithili verse — rejecting the ornate Alaṃkāra traditions of classical poetry in favour of a spare, accessible idiom. The influence of the Nayi Kavita (New Poetry) movement — particularly its rejection of rhyme-scheme strictures and its embrace of free verse — is apparent. Yet her poetry is not without craft: internal sound patterns, repetitions, and the deployment of folk-register vocabulary create a distinctive musicality.

The Vakrokti (oblique speech) theory of Kuntaka (10th-11th century Kashmir) is particularly illuminating here. Kuntaka argues that the essence of poetry is 'deviating expression' — saying something indirectly, with a twist. Kamat's ironic mode — where she describes dowry in the language of the vegetable market — is a sophisticated deployment of vakrokti in contemporary Maithili verse.

## 2.2 Seed Stories (Bīhani Kathā / Vihaṇi Kathā)

### *2.2.1 The Bīhani Kathā Tradition*

The Bīhani Kathā (literally 'morning tale' or 'seed story') is a distinctive Maithili literary form — a very short narrative, often a single scene or vignette, that plants a seed of meaning without exhausting it. The Videha Parallel History Framework (Part 32) situates the Bīhani Kathā as a specific Maithili contribution to world micro-fiction, with roots in the oral tradition and

connections to both the Sanskrit Kathā tradition and the modern flash fiction movement.

Kamat's seed stories, collected in the second section of Sukhal Man Tarsal Āṃkhi, demonstrate a mastery of compression. Each story creates a complete world in a minimal space — enacting the Dhvani principle that the unstated resonates more powerfully than the stated.

### *2.2.2 Themes of the Seed Stories*

The seed stories address themes consistent with the poetry: domestic conflict, the position of women, economic hardship, village life, and the violence — both overt and structural — that shapes daily existence in rural Mithila. They operate in the realist mode, drawing on the lived texture of Maithili village society, yet achieving an allegorical resonance that transcends the local.

Applying the Navya-Nyāya analytical technique of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya — which insists on precise identification of the cognising subject (pramātā), the means of knowledge (pramāṇa), the object known (prameya), and the valid cognition (pramā) — we can say that Kamat's seed stories deploy narrative as a pramāṇa for knowing social reality. The 'anuvyavasāya' (meta-cognition or reflective awareness) built into the reader's encounter with these stories constitutes the epistemological payoff of reading them.

## 2.3 One-Act Plays (Ekaṅkī-Nāṭak)

### *2.3.1 Overview of the Plays*

The one-act play section of Sukhal Man Tarsal Āṃkhi contains four plays: 'Pāt-pātsa banala parivār' (Family Made of Leaves and Leaves), 'Shikshit beti' (The Educated Daughter), 'Andhviśvās' (Superstition), and 'Zindagi ka mol' (The Value of Life). Each play is structured in multiple scenes (Dṛśya) with curtain drops (Paṭop) marking transitions — following the standard one-act theatrical format.

### *2.3.2 'Pāt-pātsa banala parivār' — Family Conflict and Joint Family*

The first play stages a conflict within a joint family household, centring on the rivalry between a 'Baṛki Bhauji' (elder sister-in-law) and a 'Chhoṭki' (younger sister-in-law). The play dramatises how domestic conflict escalates from verbal abuse to physical violence against children, forcing a reckoning with the question of whether joint family life is sustainable. The play ends with an elder's speech — structurally resembling the deus ex machina but made

ideologically complex — arguing that the joint family is like a body: 'Just as pain in one organ reaches the whole body, so does sorrow in one family member reach all.'

The play demonstrates Kamat's skill in capturing the social texture of Maithili village life. In Nāṭyaśāstra terms, the play's Sthāyibhāva (dominant emotion) is Karuṇa (pathos/compassion), with the violence against the child and the domestic unhappiness activating the Rasa of sorrow. The resolution — provisional reconciliation rather than utopian harmony — is realistic rather than moralistic.

From an Aristotelian perspective, the play has a clear beginning (exposition of the conflict), middle (escalation and violence), and end (attempted resolution) — fulfilling the Aristotelian criterion of unified plot structure. The Hamartia here is not a personal tragic flaw but a structural one: the incompatibility of social pressures within the joint family system.

### *2.3.3 'Shikshit beti' — The Educated Daughter*

This play is among Kamat's most directly social-reformist. Dulari, a village girl, achieves the highest marks in her district in the board examination — but her mother Phuladai has already torn up her mark sheet, beaten her, and tried to suppress her education in favour of marriage and domestic work. The drama traces Dulari's vindication when her teacher arrives to honour her publicly, and the mother's belated transformation.

The play's dramatic arc follows what Brecht would recognise as a Lehrstück (learning play) — a play designed not for catharsis but for instruction and social change. The audience is invited not to identify emotionally with the characters but to learn from the social contradictions dramatised. The explicit moral — a final choral verse about boys and girls studying together until the difference between them disappears — confirms this didactic intention.

Yet the play also has genuine emotional texture. Dulari's silence — weeping without speaking — enacts what in Nāṭyaśāstra terms is a Sāttvikābhāva (involuntary physical manifestation of emotion): the speechless grief of a child whose creativity has been crushed. The teacher's arrival activates a reversal of fortune that is both dramatically satisfying and thematically pointed.

Applying feminist theory, the play illustrates Nancy Chodorow's analysis of mother-daughter reproduction of gender norms: it is the mother who suppresses the daughter's education, having internalised patriarchal values. The play

critiques not only patriarchy but women's complicity in its reproduction — making it more nuanced than straightforward victim-rescue narratives.

### *2.3.4 'Andhviśvās' — Superstition*

This play dramatises a family whose son Shankar falls ill. The parents, Rama and Ganga, initially attribute the illness to supernatural possession and resort to rituals, animal sacrifice, and a local tantric (Rama). The play turns on the arrival of Raghunath, an educated young man from the city, who diagnoses 'dimagi bukhār' (brain fever/encephalitis) and urges immediate hospitalisation. The play ends with Rama's awakening: 'You have opened my eyes today. Come, let's take the son to hospital.'

The play is a piece of rational, enlightenment theatre — opposing medical science to superstitious practice. In Brechtian terms, it functions as a gestus: the social gesture of ritual animal sacrifice as a substitute for medical treatment crystallises an entire system of material and ideological relations. The play does not demonise the parents — their fear is rendered with genuine compassion — but locates the cause of their dangerous choices in structural poverty and lack of access to education and healthcare.

From the Nāṭyaśāstra's analysis of dramatic types (Nāṭikā, Prakaraṇa etc.), this play corresponds most closely to a Prakaraṇa — a drama of social life with invented characters, depicting contemporary social themes, as distinguished from the Nāṭaka which deals with royal or heroic subject matter. Bharata lists social plays as appropriate for instructing and delighting common audiences, and Kamat's plays fulfil this function precisely.

### *2.3.5 'Zindagi ka mol' — The Value of Life*

The most sombre of Kamat's plays, 'Zindagi ka mol' (The Value of Life) follows Ram Ratan, an eighteen-year-old from a village who travels to Himachal Pradesh for work, only to be used as an unwitting human guinea pig by a pharmaceutical company — administered overdoses of drugs in clinical trials. He dies. His elderly father Bhikhan, who lives alone, awaits the news. The play ends with the revelation of Ram Ratan's death for eight thousand rupees — the payment for his participation in the trial.

This play marks a significant expansion of Kamat's political imagination. It moves from the domestic (family conflict, education) to the systemic (pharmaceutical exploitation of rural migrant labour). The final confrontation between Bhikhan and Phulchan — 'You traded my son's life for eight thousand

rupees... today my son died, tomorrow someone else's son will die. Why is this game of death played?' — is rhetorically devastating and politically radical.

In Marxist dramatic theory (Lukács, Williams), this play belongs to the tradition of social realism that seeks to represent not individual psychology but the totality of social forces. The 'type' figures — the poor father, the naive rural boy, the corporate doctor, the complicit friend — are not flat characters but crystallisations of social positions. The play's Tragic structure — Ram Ratan's death is both preventable and inevitable, given the socio-economic conditions — places it in dialogue with classical tragedy while grounding it in contemporary political economy.

## 2.4 The Novel: Māṭik Suwas (माटिक सुवास)

Māṭik Suwas ('The Fragrance of Earth') is Kamat's first novel, published in 2023 by Navarambh Prakashan. The title — invoking the petrichor, the smell of earth after rain — suggests a novel deeply rooted in the landscape, memory, and sensory texture of Mithila. The writing is reflecting the reality of contemporary Maithili life where English has penetrated village communication through mobile phones and migrant workers.

The novel represents a major formal development in Kamat's career — the shift from the compressed forms (lyric poetry, seed story, one-act play) to the expansive novelistic form that can accommodate multiple characters, time-frames, and social dimensions. The title's invocation of 'the fragrance of earth' suggests a novel deeply concerned with rootedness, dispossession, and the relationship between Maithili speakers and their land.

Mikhail Bakhtin's theory of the novel as a 'polyphonic' form — a genre of competing voices and dialogues, in contrast to the monologic epic — is particularly relevant here. Kamat's novelistic project appears to be precisely a polyphonic engagement with Maithili social life, bringing together the voices that have been suppressed or marginalised in the official canon.

# III. Critical Frameworks and Theoretical Analysis

## 3.1 The Nāṭyaśāstra Framework

### *3.1.1 Bharata's Nāṭyaśāstra and Kamat's Dramatic Practice*

The Nāṭyaśāstra of Bharata Muni (c. 200 BCE–200 CE) is the foundational treatise of Indian performing arts, encompassing dance, music, and drama. Its analysis of Rasa (aesthetic emotion), Bhāva (emotional state), Abhinaya (performance), Nāṭyadharmi and Lokadharmi (stylised and realistic performance modes), and dramatic structure provides an indispensable framework for reading Kamat's plays.

Bharata identifies eight primary Rasas: Śṛṅgāra (love/beauty), Hāsya (humour), Karuṇa (compassion/sorrow), Raudra (fury), Vīra (heroism), Bhayānaka (terror), Bībhatsa (disgust), Adbhuta (wonder). Later tradition added Śānta (tranquility) as a ninth. Kamat's dramatic works primarily activate Karuṇa, Raudra, and Bībhatsa — with occasional passages of Vīra (in the resistance of educated daughters, enlightened teachers, and the awakened father in 'Andhviśvās').

The theory of Vibhāva, Anubhāva, and Vyabhicāribhāva is central to how Kamat's drama works. The Vibhāvas (excitants) are the social conditions depicted — dowry, illiteracy, superstition, pharmaceutical exploitation. The Anubhāvas (consequent expressions) are the characters' visible reactions — weeping, silence, rage, transformation. The Vyabhicāribhāvas (transient emotional states) — anxiety, hope, despair, indignation — traverse the dramatic action, enriching the dominant Rasa.

Bharata's insistence that drama must be both entertaining (āhlāda) and instructive (śikṣā) — that it must 'serve as a guide to people in time of grief, fatigue, or sorrow' (Nāṭyaśāstra 1.106-107) — is precisely the programme Kamat's plays fulfil. Her theatre is both socially engaged and aesthetically crafted; it uses the pleasure of performance to communicate social critique.

### *3.1.2 Dramatic Structure and Sanskrit Poetics*

The Nāṭyaśāstra identifies five stages of dramatic action (Avasthā): Ārambha (beginning), Yatna (effort), Prāptyāśā (possibility of attainment), Niyatāpti (certainty of attainment), and Phalāgama (achievement of result). Kamat's plays can be mapped onto this five-stage structure, though her social-realist

outcomes often subvert the expected triumphalist conclusion: in 'Zindagi ka mol,' the 'Phalāgama' is the death of Ram Ratan — a tragic inversion of the expected achievement.

The theory of Sandhi (junctures) — Mukha (opening), Pratimukha (progression), Garbha (development), Vimarśa (pause/reflection), and Nirvahaṇa (conclusion) — is also operative in analysing Kamat's dramatic structure. Her plays demonstrate a compression of this five-sandhi structure into the one-act format, with each scene (Dṛśya) corresponding roughly to a sandhi.

## 3.2 Rasa-Dhvani Aesthetics

### *3.2.1 Ānandavardhana's Dhvani Theory*

Ānandavardhana's Dhvanyāloka (9th century) argues that the highest poetry is characterised by Dhvani — 'resonance' or 'suggestion' — where the unstated meaning (vyañjanā) transcends and deepens the stated meaning (vācyārtha). The three levels of meaning — vācyārtha (literal), lakṣaṇārtha (indicative), and vyañjanārtha (suggestive) — form a hierarchy in which the suggestive level carries the greatest aesthetic power.

Kamat's title 'Sukhal man tarsal āṃkhi' operates at all three levels. The literal meaning (dry heart, longing eyes) is the vācyārtha. The indicative meaning (lakṣaṇā) points to the condition of suppressed Maithili women. The suggestive resonance (Dhvani) is the entire history of Mithila's patriarchal and caste-based social structure, its beauty and its violence, its fertility and its drought — a resonance that pervades the entire volume and connects it to the landscape of Mithila itself.

### *3.2.2 Abhinavagupta's Aesthetic Theory*

Abhinavagupta (10th-11th century Kashmir) developed Ānandavardhana's Dhvani theory into a comprehensive aesthetics of rasa-recognition. In his Abhinavabhāratī (commentary on the Nāṭyaśāstra), he argues that aesthetic experience (rasāsvādana) is a form of brahmanānda-sahodara — a cousin of the bliss of Brahman. The spectator or reader transcends their individual subjectivity to experience a universal, generalised emotional state.

The relevance to Kamat's writing is this: her poems and plays, while rooted in specific Maithili village realities, aspire to and achieve this universalisation. The dowry victim is not only a Maithili woman; the superstitious father is not only a Mithila villager; the pharmaceutical guinea pig is not only a Bihar

migrant worker. These are universally recognisable human conditions, rendered in their particular social specificity — precisely the movement Abhinavagupta identifies as the aesthetic transformation of particular emotion into universal Rasa.

## 3.3 Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya

### *3.3.1 Gaṅgeśa and the Tattvacintāmaṇi*

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (c. 13th-14th century, Mithila) is the founder of Navya-Nyāya (New Logic), a school of Indian epistemology that developed a precise, formal technical vocabulary for analysing knowledge claims. His Tattvacintāmaṇi ('Thought-jewel of Ontology') is the foundational text. Significantly — and this is a key finding of the Videha Parallel History — Gaṅgeśa was born of an inter-caste union (his mother was a Charmakāriṇī, of the leather-tanning community) and this fact was systematically suppressed by the upper-caste literary establishment. Gaṅgeśa thus belongs to the suppressed democratic tradition that the Videha framework recovers.

The technical vocabulary of Navya-Nyāya provides a rigorous instrument for literary analysis. Key concepts include: Pramāṇa (means of knowledge: perception, inference, comparison, testimony); Pramātā (the knowing subject); Prameya (the object of knowledge); Pramā (valid cognition); Vyāpti (invariable concomitance, the basis of inference); Pakṣatā (the subjective condition that drives inquiry); and Anuvyavasāya (meta-cognition, or awareness of one's own awareness).

### *3.3.2 Applying Navya-Nyāya to Kamat's Literary Practice*

The Navya-Nyāya framework, applied to Kamat's writing, reveals several important epistemological dimensions:

First, Kamat's poetry functions as a Pramāṇa — a means of valid knowledge — for Maithili social reality. The poem is not merely an aesthetic object but an instrument of knowledge: it enables valid cognition (Pramā) of conditions (dowry violence, illiteracy, superstition, pharmaceutical exploitation) that are otherwise invisible to mainstream discourse. This is the literary equivalent of Nyāya's concept of Anumāna (inference) from visible signs to hidden realities.

Second, the Navya-Nyāya concept of Vyāpti (invariable concomitance — 'wherever there is smoke, there is fire') can be applied to Kamat's social analysis. Her poems establish, through accumulated specific instances, the vyāpti: 'wherever there is patriarchal Mithila, there is the suppression of female

education'; 'wherever there is rural poverty, there is vulnerability to pharmaceutical exploitation.' The literary text functions as the medium for establishing these social invariances.

Third, the concept of Pakṣatā — the subjective condition of inquiry, the lived doubt or uncertainty that drives the search for knowledge — illuminates Kamat's position as a writer. She writes from a position of pakṣatā: she has lived the conditions she writes about, and her writing is driven by the need to know, to understand, and to transform these conditions. This is not merely biographical but epistemological: her particular social location as a Maithili woman writer enables a distinctive mode of knowing.

Fourth, the Navya-Nyāya distinction between laukika (worldly) and alaukika (extraordinary) pratyakṣa (perception) is relevant to the heightened perception that literary experience enables. Kamat's dramatic scene of a child's bleeding mouth after being struck — rendered with vivid sensory detail — constitutes a form of alaukika pratyakṣa, enabling the reader to perceive social violence with an immediacy that transcends ordinary perception.

## 3.4 The Videha Parallel History Framework

### *3.4.1 The Parallel Tradition and Institutional Critique*

The Videha Parallel History Framework, developed by Gajendra Thakur through the Videha eJournal (www.videha.co.in), constitutes the most important contemporary critical framework for evaluating Kamat's work. This framework argues that Maithili literary history as institutionally constructed (primarily by the Sahitya Akademi, Delhi) has systematically promoted an upper-caste (predominantly Maithil Brahmin) canon while suppressing democratic, folk, Dalit, feminist, and Nepal-side traditions.

A Right to Information (RTI) inquiry filed by Vinit Utpal and Ashish Anchinhar (2011-14) revealed that over 90% of Sahitya Akademi translation and publication assignments went to friends and relatives of the ten-member advisory board — confirming what Videha had documented through critical analysis. This institutional critique is not merely sociological: it has direct implications for how Kamat's work is read and valued.

### *3.4.2 Kamat in the Parallel Tradition*

Within the Videha Parallel History, Kamat is positioned explicitly in the 'Women's Writing: The Suppressed Canon' — alongside Vibha Rani, Kamini Kamayani, Susmita Pathak, Premlata Mishra Prem, Panna Jha, and Kalpana

Jha. The Parallel History notes that women writers were 'excluded from Sahitya Akademi assignments entirely' (confirmed by RTI data). The first anthology of Maithili women poets, Ijoriyak Angaithi-Mor (edited by Mala Jha and Vibha Jha), represents a parallel-tradition corrective to this exclusion.

Kamat's positioning in this framework has two implications. First, her work must be read against the grain of the institutional canon — as a counter-voice, a democratic intervention, a recovery of suppressed social realities. Second, her work participates in what the Videha framework calls the 'Videha era' — the digital counter-archive that has created a million pages of Maithili corpus outside institutional channels, enabling writers like Kamat to publish, circulate, and reach readers without depending on Sahitya Akademi patronage.

### *3.4.3 The Bīhani Kathā Tradition and Videha*

The Videha Parallel History (Part 32) specifically addresses the Bīhani Kathā (Seed Story) tradition as a distinctive Maithili literary form. Kamat's seed stories in Sukhal Man Tarsal Āṃkhi belong to this tradition — a form that the Videha framework identifies as both artistically significant and institutionally neglected. The seed story's democratic brevity (accessible to readers with limited literary education), its roots in oral tradition, and its radical compression make it a form particularly suited to the parallel tradition's project of democratising Maithili literature.

## 3.5 Western Critical Frameworks

### *3.5.1 Feminist Literary Theory*

Simone de Beauvoir's foundational insight in The Second Sex — that woman is constructed as the 'Other' against which man defines himself — pervades Kamat's entire literary project. Her poems, plays, and stories are precisely a documentation of this construction of woman-as-Other in Maithili society, and a resistance to it. The mother who tears up her daughter's exam results is not simply a 'bad mother' but a woman who has internalised the patriarchal construction of her daughter as Other (destined for marriage, not education).

Elaine Showalter's concept of 'gynocriticism' — the study of women's writing as a distinct literary tradition — provides a useful framework for reading Kamat's work not as a deviation from a male norm but as participation in a women's literary tradition that has its own conventions, concerns, and aesthetic strategies. In Maithili, this tradition includes the Sāmā Cākeva songs, the Vat-

Savitri rituals, and the oral lore of Maithili women — a tradition that Kamat both inherits and transforms.

### *3.5.2 Postcolonial Theory*

Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's question 'Can the subaltern speak?' — and her answer that the subaltern is systematically denied the conditions of speech within the colonial and postcolonial order — is directly relevant to Kamat's project. Her subalterns are multiple: rural Maithili women, migrant workers, village families trapped in superstition for lack of healthcare access. Her literary project is precisely the construction of conditions under which these subjects can speak — and be heard.

Homi Bhabha's concept of 'hybridity' — the in-between space created by colonial and postcolonial cultural encounters — illuminates Kamat's bilingual novel Māṭik Suwas, where Maithili and English intermingle in the dialogue of characters navigating between village and city, between traditional and modern, between Mithila and Himachal Pradesh.

### *3.5.3 Aristotelian and Epic Theatre*

The tension between Aristotelian and Brechtian dramatic theory is productive for reading Kamat's plays. Aristotle's Poetics defines tragedy as 'the imitation of an action that is serious, complete, and of a certain magnitude... through pity and fear effecting the proper purgation of these emotions' (catharsis). Kamat's plays engage with this model — they activate pity (for Dulari, for Bhikhan, for the possessed Shankar) and fear (at the violence of the domestic and social world) — but her endings resist the Aristotelian cathartic resolution. There is no purging of social emotion; rather, a residue of unresolved social critique that demands action outside the theatre.

Brecht's counter-theory — that theatre should not produce cathartic identification but Verfremdungseffekt (estrangement), enabling the audience to see familiar social arrangements as contingent and changeable — is equally operative. The final verse of 'Shikshit beti,' with its didactic resolution, is closer to Brecht's Lehrstück than to Aristotelian tragedy. Kamat's theatre oscillates between these two poles — using emotional engagement to open the audience, and rational critique to challenge them.

### *3.5.4 New Historicism and Cultural Materialism*

Stephen Greenblatt's New Historicism argues that literary texts are embedded in specific historical moments and cannot be read apart from the social,

political, and economic conditions of their production. Applied to Kamat, this means reading her plays and poems in the context of: the post-2003 recognition of Maithili in the Eighth Schedule; the RTI exposure of Sahitya Akademi corruption; the crisis of the pharmaceutical industry's exploitation of rural trial participants; the ongoing struggles over land, water, and women's education in Bihar; and the digital revolution that has enabled Videha to create a parallel literary infrastructure.

Raymond Williams's concept of the 'structure of feeling' — the particular affective landscape of a given historical moment, not yet fully articulated in formal ideology — is also relevant. Kamat's writing captures the structure of feeling of contemporary Mithila: the simultaneous aspiration for education and mobility, the persistence of traditional patriarchal structures, the vulnerability to new forms of exploitation (pharmaceutical, migrant labour), and the emergence of women's voices that refuse to be silenced.

## 3.6 Theatre and Performance Theory

### *3.6.1 Stanislavski and the Realist Tradition*

Constantin Stanislavski's system — particularly his emphasis on 'living through' the role, on finding the 'given circumstances' of the character, and on the 'through-line of action' — is relevant to the performance dimensions of Kamat's plays. Her characters are psychologically coherent and socially specific in ways that demand this kind of interior engagement from actors. The mother Phuladai in 'Shikshit beti,' who tears up her daughter's exam results, must be played not as a villain but as a woman with a comprehensible, if tragically mistaken, set of values and fears.

### *3.6.2 Folk and Traditional Maithili Performance Traditions*

Kamat's plays draw on Maithili folk performance traditions — the Bidapadia (itinerant theatre), the Jhumar singing tradition, and the Lokanatya forms that have evolved in the Mithila region. The use of curtain drops (Paṭop) as scene markers, the direct address to the audience in some plays, and the incorporation of sung verses at key dramatic moments all connect her work to this indigenous performance tradition.

The Ankiya Natak tradition of Assam (associated with the Vaishnava reformer Sankaradeva) — which also uses the one-act form to dramatise devotional and social themes — provides another point of comparison. Both the Ankiya Natak

and Kamat's Ekaṅkī use the compressed one-act form for maximum didactic effect, and both are intended for popular, non-elite audiences.

### *3.6.3 Bechan Thakur and the Maithili Parallel Stage*

The Videha Parallel History identifies Bechan Thakur as 'the greatest living Maithili dramatist' who 'created a parallel Maithili stage that confronts caste violence directly.' Kamat's dramatic work participates in this parallel stage tradition — distinct from the slapstick commercial Maithili theatre that dominates popular performance venues, and engaged with the serious theatrical tradition that addresses social injustice directly.

# IV. Thematic and Ideological Analysis

## 4.1 Gender, Patriarchy, and Women's Resistance

Across all genres — poetry, seed story, play, and novel — Kamat's central preoccupation is the condition of women in Maithili patriarchal society and the possibilities of resistance. Her women characters are neither passive victims nor heroic rebels in the conventional sense: they are complex social beings whose choices are constrained by the material and ideological conditions of their lives.

The figure of the daughter recurs across Kamat's work: the daughter whose birth extinguishes the lamp, the daughter whose exam results are torn up, the daughter who is traded in dowry. This is not mere repetition but a systematic investigation of the structure of patriarchal devaluation — from birth through education through marriage through widowhood — that constitutes the life-course of women in Mithila.

The resistance in Kamat's work is typically small-scale, local, and hard-won. Dulari's quiet weeping before her eventual vindication; the educated young man from the city who challenges superstition; the father who belatedly recognises the value of his daughter's achievement — these are not revolutionary transformations but incremental shifts in consciousness. This realism about the pace of social change is one of Kamat's most important literary qualities.

## 4.2 Caste, Class, and Social Hierarchy

While Kamat does not always name caste explicitly, the social hierarchies she depicts are shot through with caste logic. The Mithila she writes about is a caste society, and the vulnerabilities she depicts — to poverty, to domestic violence, to pharmaceutical exploitation — are differentially distributed along caste lines. The Videha Parallel History's emphasis on recovering the suppressed democratic and Dalit traditions of Maithili literature provides the critical framework within which to read Kamat's social analyses.

The play 'Zindagi ka mol' is particularly telling here: the rural migrant worker who becomes a pharmaceutical guinea pig is vulnerable precisely because he lacks the social capital (education, urban networks, legal knowledge) that upper-caste and class privilege would provide. The eight-thousand-rupee 'compensation' for his death — casually offered by the pharmaceutical

company — encapsulates the brutal logic of class and caste privilege in the valuation of human lives.

## 4.3 The Rural-Urban Divide

A significant dimension of Kamat's thematic universe is the tension between rural Mithila and the urban centres (Patna, Delhi, Himachal Pradesh) to which its people migrate for work and education. This rural-urban axis is the site of both aspiration and danger: the city offers education, mobility, and economic opportunity, but also exploitation, displacement, and loss of cultural rootedness.

The title of her novel, Māṭik Suwas ('The Fragrance of Earth'), encodes this tension: 'earth' is the village, the ancestral land, the roots; 'fragrance' is the memory and longing for what has been left behind or threatened. The novel appears to be a sustained meditation on this dialectic of rootedness and mobility.

## 4.4 Superstition, Science, and Enlightenment

The play 'Andhviśvās' places Kamat in a long tradition of Indian social-reformist literature — from Kabir's critique of ritual to Phule's critique of Brahminism to the contemporary rationalist tradition. Her treatment of superstition is, however, notably non-condescending: the parents who resort to ritual animal sacrifice are not villains but frightened people who lack access to healthcare. The critique is structural rather than moralistic.

This positions Kamat's rationalism in the tradition of Ambedkar's Buddhist rationalism — a critique of irrationality that is simultaneously a critique of the social structures (poverty, caste, exclusion from education) that produce and maintain irrationality. The final verse of 'Andhviśvās' — 'Giving life for life / is the bondage of superstition / Let us pledge / not to take anyone's life' — is a call not only for individual enlightenment but for social transformation.

# V. Literary Significance and Critical Evaluation

## 5.1 Contribution to Maithili Literature

Munni Kamat's contribution to Maithili literature is threefold. First, she has produced a body of work in all major literary genres — poetry, short prose, drama, and the novel — demonstrating rare formal versatility. Second, she has consistently addressed themes (women's education, dowry, superstition, pharmaceutical exploitation of labour) that the institutional Maithili canon has largely ignored. Third, she has produced this work in a period of genuine difficulty for Maithili literature — when the institutional mechanisms of recognition and distribution remain controlled by networks that systematically exclude parallel-tradition voices.

Her tripartite volume Sukhal Man Tarsal Āṃkhi — combining poems, seed stories, and one-act plays in a single volume — is itself a formal innovation, demonstrating the organic connections between these forms in her creative practice. The title poem/title principle unifies the volume into a coherent artistic statement rather than a miscellany.

## 5.2 Relationship to Predecessors and Contemporaries

Kamat's work stands in a clear lineage of Maithili women's writing — from the oral tradition of Maithili women's folk songs (the Sāmā Cākeva songs, for instance), through the colonial-era educated women writers who began to enter the literary public sphere, to her contemporary parallel-tradition peers: Vibha Rani, Kamini Kamayani, Premlata Mishra Prem, and Panna Jha.

Among the canonical male tradition, her closest points of contact are the social-realist writers: Harimohan Jha (for satirical critique of social customs), Rajkamal Chaudhary (for avant-garde formal innovation and political radicalism), and Bechan Thakur (for politically engaged popular drama). Her work represents a feminist inflection of the social-realist tradition, bringing the distinctive epistemological position of a woman writer to bear on the same social conditions.

## 5.3 Limitations and Areas for Further Research

Several aspects of Kamat's work require further critical investigation. The novel Māṭik Suwas, published only in 2023, has not yet received the critical

attention it merits. A full analysis of its narrative structure, its deployment of Maithili-English code-switching, and its relationship to the traditions of Indian women's fiction (Mahadevi Varma, Ismat Chughtai, Mahasweta Devi) would be valuable.

Additionally, the performance history of Kamat's one-act plays — their staging, reception, and social impact in actual Maithili communities — requires documentation. Literary analysis of dramatic texts divorced from their performance context risks missing crucial dimensions of their aesthetic and social effectiveness.

Finally, a comparative analysis of Kamat's work alongside the Bīhani Kathā tradition as documented by Videha, and alongside women's short fiction in other Indian regional traditions (Bengali, Oriya, Awadhi), would help situate her in the broader landscape of Indian women's democratic literature.

## VI. Conclusion: Munni Kamat and the Democratic Future of Maithili Literature

Munni Kamat stands as a significant voice in the democratic, feminist, and social-realist tradition of Maithili literature that the Videha Parallel History Framework has worked to recover and promote. Her work — across poetry, seed story, one-act play, and novel — constitutes a sustained engagement with the social conditions of Mithila's marginalised majorities: women, the poor, migrant workers, families trapped in structural vulnerabilities. Her writing is both aesthetically crafted and politically committed, demonstrating that these two qualities are not in tension but mutually reinforcing.

Applying the convergent frameworks of this study — Bharata's Nāṭyaśāstra, Rasa-Dhvani aesthetics, Navya-Nyāya epistemology, the Videha Parallel History, feminist theory, Brechtian drama, and postcolonial criticism — reveals the richness and complexity of a body of work that, under institutional conditions of fair recognition, would already be widely studied and celebrated. The task of criticism, in this context, is not only aesthetic evaluation but institutional correction: to insist, with the rigour that Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya applied to knowledge claims, that valid literary cognition requires inclusion of the suppressed tradition.

The Navya-Nyāya concept of Anuvyavasāya — meta-cognition, the awareness of our awareness — is, finally, the critical activity this study enacts. We must be aware not only of Kamat's texts but of the conditions under which they were written, published, and received (or not received) — the institutional, social, and political conditions that shape the literary field. Only then can we achieve the Pramā (valid cognition) that Kamat's work both represents and demands.

*"The dry heart longs / the thirsty eye seeks — / in both the wound is real / and in the wound the fire of transformation."* **— After Munni Kamat, Sukhal Man Tarsal Āṃkhi**

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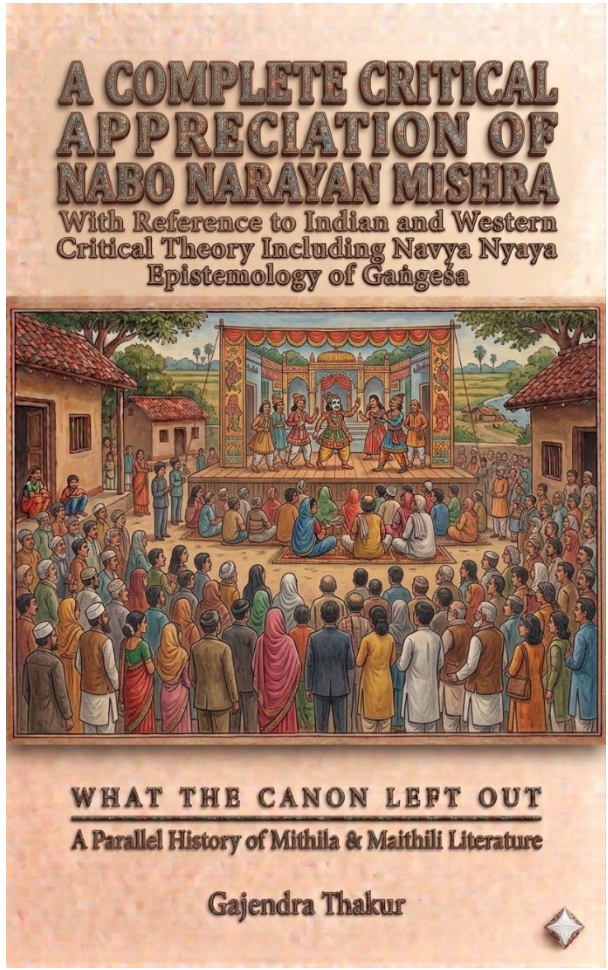
**LESSON 048 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**




# A COMPLETE CRITICAL APPRECIATION OF

# NABO NARAYAN MISHRA

*(b. 7 May 1955, Kushmaul, Madhubani)*

With Reference to Indian and Western Critical Theory

*Including Navya Nyaya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa*

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# I. PREFACE AND SCOPE OF THE STUDY

Nabo Narayan Mishra occupies a distinctive and important, if relatively underexplored, position in contemporary Maithili literature. Born on 7 May 1955 in Kushmaul village, Nagadih-Balain post, Madhubani district, Bihar, he spent a formative part of his adult life as a Maithili cultural activist in Kolkata, where he served for two decades as Secretary of the Kokil Manch, one of the most active Maithili literary and theatrical organisations in the diaspora. After retirement from service, he returned to his native village, where he continues his literary engagement.

The publication of Nabo Narayan Mishra Samagra (2026), edited by Ashish Anichhinhar and made available through the Videha e-journal platform (www.videha.co.in/pothi.htm), represents the first systematic collection of his scattered creative and critical output. The 199-page volume brings together three interviews he conducted with distinguished Maithili figures, fifteen essays on literary personalities and institutional history, eleven short stories, and seventeen poems, together with a biographical appendix and facsimiles of two handwritten essays. The volume is dedicated to the Creator (Srijanhaar) and opens with an invocation from the Shanti Mantra of the Yajurveda, setting a tone of cultural rootedness that runs through Mishra's entire oeuvre.

The present critical appreciation examines this Samagra in depth, applying both Western critical frameworks (New Criticism, narratology, postcolonialism, Marxist criticism) and Indian critical traditions (Rasa theory, Dhvani theory, and, centrally, the Navya Nyaya epistemology of Gangesa Upadhyaya of Mithila). The purpose is not merely to describe but to evaluate: to assess where Mishra's work achieves genuine literary distinction and where it reflects the constraints of the Maithili diaspora literary milieu in which it was produced.

# II. BIOGRAPHICAL OVERVIEW

Nabo Narayan Mishra was born on 7 May 1955 in Kushmaul, a village in Nagadih-Balain, Madhubani district, Bihar, to Shri Govind Mishra (deceased) and Shrimati (deceased). He completed his education and subsequently took up employment in a private firm in Kolkata, where he settled and remained for most of his professional life.

In Kolkata, he became deeply embedded in the Maithili cultural network. He joined the Kokil Manch, the Maithili theatrical and cultural organisation founded under the leadership of Ganga Jha, and served as its Secretary for an unbroken period of twenty years. During this tenure, he was instrumental in organising annual theatrical productions, poetry gatherings (Kavigoshti), and cultural programmes at venues including the Mahajati Sadan, Netaji Subhash Institution, and other Kolkata stages.

His literary connections were wide. He was a close associate of the poet-playwright Ramlochan Thakur (b. 18 March 1949, Baabu Paali, Madhubani), whom he accompanied to various literary events until Thakur's final years. He knew Rajanandan Lal Das, the long-serving editor of Karnamrit; Prof. Prabodh Narayan Singh, the Maithili movement leader in Kolkata; Pitambar Pathak, the movement activist; Lakshman Jha Sagar, the poet; and Sumangshu Shekhar Choudhary, the editor and playwright. He also interviewed Kishorikant Mishra (former president, Mithila Sanskritik Parishad, Kolkata) and Dr. Virendra Mallick for Videha.

In 2020, Mishra retired from service and returned to his native village. The Samagra, published in 2026, collects his lifetime output, much of which was published across various Maithili periodicals in scattered form. His hobbies are listed as organisation work, theatre, literary and social activities.

## III. THE SAMAGRA: STRUCTURE AND CONTENTS

The Nabo Narayan Mishra Samagra is structured in four principal divisions, preceded by dedication and prefatory matter and followed by appendices.

### *Prefatory Matter*

The book opens with the Tirhuta script symbol (the auspicious marker), followed by the Yajurveda Shanti Mantra invoking peace in all realms. The editorial preface by Ashish Anichhinhar provides the rationale for the collection: that Mishra never aspired to be recognised as a "writer" in the conventional sense, producing work not for recognition but out of inner compulsion; that of contemporary Kolkata-based Maithili writers, Mishra has written most extensively on Kolkata and Kolkata-related subjects on a proportional basis; and that the Samagra gives readers access to a body of work that was otherwise lost in the scattered pages of various periodicals.

***Division I: Prose — Interviews (Sakshatkaar)***

**Interview 1:** Kishorikant Mishra (former President, Mithila Sanskritik Parishad, Kolkata). Conducted for Videha. Covers the history of the Parishad, the census agitation for Maithili, the standardisation of Maithili script and vocabulary, and the contribution of Kolkata to the Maithili literary movement.

**Interview 2:** Sri Ramlochan Thakur (conducted for Videha on the occasion of his receiving the Samanantar Sahitya Akademi award). Covers Thakur's engagement with Maithili theatre, his literary journey, his poetry and its reception, and his reflections on the Maithili movement.

**Interview 3:** Dr. Virendra Mallick (conducted for Videha, prepared for the proposed Virendra Mallick special issue which was ultimately not published). Contains 16 substantive questions covering poetic theory, the state of Maithili literature, institutionalisation, caste dynamics in literary organisations, and intergenerational responsibility.

***Division II: Prose — Essays (Aalekh)***

Fifteen essays covering literary personalities (Ramlochan Thakur, Rajanandan Lal Das, Prof. Prabodh Narayan Singh, Lakshman Jha Sagar, Pitambar Pathak, Babu Saheb Choudhary, Ajay Singh, Prabhash Choudhary) and institutional/cultural histories (Mithila Vikas Parishad Kolkata, Kolkata ka Maithili Andolan aur Mithila Darshan, Mithila Mihir aur Sampadaki, Hari Anant Hari Katha Ananta on Ramlochan Thakur, Maithili Rangmanch aur Kolkata). Also includes two essays on Maithili folk literature.

***Division III: Prose — Stories (Katha)***

Eleven short stories: Ehno Hoit Chhai, Ekata Pakal Aam, Yatraak Feri, Kaalachakra, Aadarsh Vivah, Paropkaarark Phal, Karod-patiik Kamaatha, Maithliii Maryaadaa, Sundar-Sanyog, Yugadharma, and Ghamandak Phal.

***Division IV: Poetry (Padya)***

Seventeen poems: Nav Varshaak Sandarbh Me (his first published poem, 1977), Prithviik Bhaar, Ee Kirtiimaan Banal, Navageet, Bidambanaa, Anant Yatraak Yaatri, Phagua, Kaniyaan Mahaaraaniik Aarti, Ekta Saahitiik Diip, Shraddhanjali, Bhagwati Vandanaa, Kichhu Lok, Sveekaar Karu Prem Aaslingan, Ee Nij Uchit Vichaar, Maithilik Ukti: Santaanak Prati, Maithili Mahootasav, Phaguak Premopahaar.

### *Appendix*

The Appendix contains facsimiles of two handwritten essays by Mishra, offered so that future readers may see his handwriting. The author biography (Lekhak Parichay) gives his name, birth date (7 May 1955), father's name (Govind Mishra), publication record, interests, profession (retired), and permanent address (Kushmaul, Nagadih-Balain, Madhubani).

## IV. ANALYSIS OF INTERVIEWS (SAKSHATKAAR)

The three interviews represent Mishra's most formally structured literary contribution. He comes to the interview not as a critic or academic but as a cultural witness and activist: someone who knew these figures personally, participated in the events being discussed, and uses the interview form to preserve institutional and personal memory.

### *The Kishorikant Mishra Interview*

This interview is historically valuable as a document of the Maithili language movement in Kolkata from 1956 onwards. Key issues addressed include: the arrival of Kishorikant Mishra in Kolkata in June 1956 with the purpose of earning and studying; the census agitation (from 1951) for Maithili to be recorded as the mother tongue of Maithil speakers; the Sahitya Akademi recognition of Maithili; the standardisation of Maithili vocabulary and orthography under the Parishad (notably the correction of the text of Vidyapati's portrait); the publication of the Maithili Ramayan; and the dynamics of Maithili organisations.

As an interviewer, Mishra is methodical and respectful. He follows a chronological logic, moving from Kishorikant Mishra's arrival in Kolkata to his engagement with the movement, to specific institutional contributions. The interview preserves important historical detail that would otherwise be lost.

### *The Ramlochan Thakur Interview*

This interview, conducted for Videha on the occasion of Thakur's Samanantar Sahitya Akademi award, reveals a warm and admiring relationship between interviewer and subject. Mishra allows Thakur to range across his theatrical career, his literary evolution, his connections with the Maithili movement, and his views on the state of Maithili writing. Thakur's observation

that in Maithili, awards cause writers to stagnate rather than progress is a pointed critique that Mishra's interview draws out effectively.

Mishra's own relationship with Thakur is documented extensively in his essay "Hari Anant Hari Katha Ananta," where he describes accompanying Thakur to literary events in Thakur's final years and his grief at Thakur's loss to Alzheimer's disease. The interview must be read alongside this essay as complementary testimony.

#### *The Virendra Mallick Interview*

The most substantive of the three, this interview contains Mallick's reflections on: the philosophical basis of fire poetry (agni-kavita); the problem of awards stagnating writers; Dalit representation in Maithili literary organisations (negligible, Mallick argues, because of Brahminical dominance); the question of the Darbhanga Peetha versus the emerging Saharsa Peetha; the ideological evolution from Marxism through Maoism; the value of ideological commitment in literary writing; and aspirations for Kolkata's youth. Mallick's comment that the Maoist slogan "Aadhaar baadi, tohar baadi, Naxalbadi" once galvanised him is an important marker of the ideological climate of Kolkata's Maithili literary world in the 1970s-80s. Mishra's 16 questions are incisive and well-prepared.

## V. ANALYSIS OF ESSAYS (AALEKH)

### V.A Essays on Literary Personalities

#### *Hamra Najorimi: Shri Ramlochan Thakur*

This essay (published in Videha's Ramlochan Thakur Special Issue, No. 319, April 2021) is Mishra's tribute to Thakur. It is written in a personal, warm register: Thakur as an icon and encyclopedia of Kolkata's Maithili world, as the co-ordinator of Samparak (a literary gathering where writers present new work for peer response), as a revolutionary figure whose couplets attacked social hypocrisy with razor sharpness. Mishra cites Thakur's famous satirical couplet on Buddhinath Mishra: "Buddhiinath Mishraak sakal rachna arthapraDhaan / Hindi me tain gawait chahi sohar aa samdaaun" — a biting critique of a writer who writes in Maithili but then performs folksongs in Hindi for patronage. The essay also describes Samparak, the informal literary group,

as functioning without a permanent president or secretary — a democratic model Mishra clearly admires.

### *Yugpurush: Shri Rajanandan Lal Das*

Two essays on Rajanandan Lal Das (published in Videha's Rajanandan Lal Das Special Issue, No. 333, November 2021) establish him as the editor of Karnamrit for thirty-six years, as a social-minded editor who published memorial issues of eighteen departed luminaries, as a playwright (Santo) and author of institutional histories. Mishra's admiration is genuine and the essays provide important primary information about Karnamrit's editorial philosophy and its progressive, anti-casteist stance.

### *Mithila-Maithilik Prabal Pakshdhara: Prof. Prabodh Babu*

The essay on Prof. Prabodh Narayan Singh (published in Karnamrit, January-March 2006) is an institutional biography of the man who founded Mithila Darshan in 1953 from Kolkata and led the Maithili movement from the city. Mishra describes his own visit with Singh at his Lake Gardens residence — the rare privilege of sitting with the movement's elder statesman and hearing accounts of the "golden era" of Maithili in Kolkata. The essay contains a poem of tribute: "Simhanaad swargahu san sunab / Jakhaan bhetait Probodh Sahitya Sammaan."

### *Sarvaguna Sampanna Sagarji*

The essay on Lakshman Jha Sagar (published in Videha's Sagar Special Issue, No. 382, November 2023) traces a friendship that began in 1990 when Mishra joined Kokil Manch. Sagar is described as a multi-genre writer (poetry, stories, essays, criticism, interviews) who combines traditional values with modern thought and whose wife Shail Jha Sagar is also a writer. The essay praises his poetry collection Ucharri Baiso Kauaa and his subsequent works.

### *Pitambar Pathak and Babu Saheb Choudhary*

The essays on Pitambar Pathak and Babu Saheb Choudhary document the Maithili movement activists of an earlier generation in Kolkata. Pathak is remembered for his agitational role — his son Vijay Pathak suffering a police baton charge in Patna during demonstrations for Maithili's Eighth Schedule recognition. Choudhary is remembered as a theatre icon who wanted to play the role of Chanakya once more in Chandraguptas Kolkata performance, who supported Kokil Manch, and who spoke bitterly of the failure to honour living writers in their lifetimes.

### V.B Essays on Institutional History

The essays on Mithila Vikas Parishad Kolkata (published in Videha Special Issue No. 408, December 2024), Kolkata ka Maithili Andolan aur Mithila Darshan, and Mithila Mihir aur Sampadaki together constitute a primary-source institutional history of the Maithili movement in Kolkata from 1933 onwards. Mishra traces the founding of Maithil Sammelan in 1933 by Pandits Kunjji Jha, Markandeya Mishra, and Babua Mishra; the emergence of Mithila Lok Sangh; the bifurcation into Akhil Bharatiya Mithila Sangh and Mithila Sanskritik Parishad; the publication of Mithila Darshan from 1953; the census agitation of 1951; and the eventual inclusion of Maithili in the Eighth Schedule in 2003.

These essays are important primary documents precisely because Mishra writes from lived participation. He attended the Delhi demonstrations; he was present at Probodh Sahitya Samman events; he knows the internal tensions between organisations. His account of how Kokil Manch eventually distanced itself from Mithila Vikas Parishad after 2006 — following a dispute over the conduct of a national seminar from which Kokil Manch was excluded — is candid institutional testimony.

### V.C Essays on Maithili Theatre

The essay "Maithili Rangmanch aur Kolkata" is the most comprehensive account available of Kokil Manch's theatrical history. It records twenty-four consecutive annual theatre productions from 1991 (Lethaait Aanchar by Sumangshu Shekhar Choudhary, directed by Ganga Jha, Mahajati Sadan, 14 November 1991) through 2006 (Pahil Saanjh, same director and venue), listing playwright, venue, director, and date for each production. This is an invaluable primary document for the history of Maithili theatre.

## VI. ANALYSIS OF STORIES (KATHA)

The eleven short stories in the Samagra range from comic social observation to moral allegory to autobiographical memory. As a group, they reflect the sensibility of an educated Maithil professional living in Kolkata who maintains deep emotional and cultural connections with his native Mithila village, and who observes the social world around him with gentle irony and occasional moral indignation.

### *Ehno Hoit Chhai (This Also Happens)*

A social comedy built around Mohanji, a well-meaning man with a short temper ("Durvasa Rishi") who is persuaded by his friend Raghav to attend a cinema in Madhubani. The story moves from the planning of the outing through its comic complications. The characterisation of Mohanji — helpful, socially engaged, but irascible — is warm and specific. The story's title carries an implicit irony: unexpected, absurd events are the texture of everyday life.

### *Ekata Pakal Aam (A Ripe Mango)*

A brief, affecting story built around a five-year-old's request that his share of the single ripe mango their father has brought home be shared with his cousin Shankar, because "eating alone is not nice to me." The child's ethical intuition — that good things must be shared — is contrasted with the adult world of calculation and competition. The story achieves its effect through economy and restraint.

### *Yatraak Feri (Journey's Round Trip)*

A story of the migrant worker's complicated relationship with home. The narrator, employed in a private firm in Kolkata whose leave requests cause his manager great pain, plans to return to his native village at Holi and Durga Puja. The story captures the psychology of the Maithili diaspora: the persistent pull of the village, the anxiety of separation from family, the complications of travel (a stalled train, a journey through rain and mud on foot through the night). The autobiographical resonance is strong.

### *Yugadharma (The Dharma of the Age)*

The most substantial and socially engaged of the stories. Lalbihhari, the eldest brother who has sacrificed his youth to educate and settle his younger siblings, now faces old age with a marriage-aged daughter, an unemployed son, and siblings who ignore him. The story shows, in a single winter night, the arc of Lalbihhari's life: his sacrifice, his reputation, and his current abandonment. The metaphor of the cold (jaad: winter cold, numbness) runs through the story, as does the warmth of the communal fire around which the village gathers. The final image of Lalbihhari huddled in a quilt, unresponsive as the villagers debate the worth of eldest sons, is quietly devastating. This story shows Mishra at his best: socially observant, emotionally restrained, and structurally controlled.

### *Ghamandak Phal (The Fruit of Arrogance)*

A moral tale about Badri Babu, a government servant who is the only educated member of his family and consequently arrogant. The story traces the consequences of pride through the education and eventual unemployment of his only son, the successful marriage of his daughter, and his eventual humbling. The story employs a traditional moral arc — pride precedes a fall — and is executed with economy.

### *Kaalachakra, Aadarsh Vivah, and Sundar-Sanyog*

Three stories exploring marriage customs and social change in Maithili society. Kaalachakra (Wheel of Time) and Aadarsh Vivah (Ideal Marriage) both engage with the tensions between tradition and modernity in matrimonial arrangements, while Sundar-Sanyog (Beautiful Coincidence) is a narrative of an unexpectedly auspicious matchmaking. The Aadarsh Vivah story is especially rich, drawn from autobiographical experience of attending a wedding ceremony in Madhubani, with a detailed rendering of the negotiations, rituals, and human comedy of a Maithili marriage.

## VII. ANALYSIS OF POETRY (PADYA)

Mishra's poetry is devotional, socially engaged, elegiac, and, occasionally, satirical. It does not aspire to modernist experiment; it works within established Maithili lyric traditions (navageet, padya) and employs regular metre, rhyme, and clear diction. Its primary values are sincerity, communal feeling, and ethical seriousness.

### *Nav Varshaak Sandarbh Me (In the Context of the New Year)*

His first published poem (1977, in a Lalit Smriti Granth), this poem mourns the passing of a Maithili luminary ("Lalit Babu") at the New Year. Its yearning — "Mann hoi, jaan vigyan joday taar-fon, / Karitahu anuroDh, puni aabiti oi dev" (I wish science could connect a telephone wire, so I could request him to return, that god) — is deeply felt and establishes his characteristic elegiac mode.

### *Prithviik Bhaar (The Weight of the Earth)*

A social-protest poem (published in Mithila Darshan, January-March 2004) addressed to a "brother" (a Maithili literary figure, identified from context as Ramlochan Thakur). It catalogues the failures of Maithili society and institutions: ambitious power-seekers, ingratitude toward predecessors, the

fragility of literary organisations, and the loneliness of genuine service. The poem ends with a rallying affirmation: service-oriented life alone is meaningful.

### *Navageet (New Song) and Bidambanaa (Irony/Predicament)*

The Navageet is a political poem with the refrain "Neta afsar ghus-khor, ee maani kai chalu" (Knowing that leaders and officials are corrupt, move on). Its regular metre, parallel structure, and folk-song rhythms align it with the navageet tradition initiated by Nagarjun/Yatri — a debt Mishra acknowledges explicitly in his poem "Ee Nij Uchit Vichaar," which is a tribute to Virendra Mallick characterised as Yatri's "ananya anuyaayi" (devoted follower). Bidambanaa is a pointed political poem on Kashmir and the treatment of Kashmiri Pandits, employing the acrostic-like repetition of its refrain with increasing indignation.

### *Anant Yatraak Yaatri (The Traveller of the Infinite Journey)*

An elegy for Nagarjun/Yatri on his death (published in Karnamrit, July-December 1999). The poem plays on "Yatri" (traveller) as both the pen name and the metaphor: "Yatriik anant yatra / aaj saahityaakaash san / samaadhi tak bheal chhai" (Yatri's infinite journey / has today gone from the literary sky / to the grave). It also touches on the bitter irony that the government that could not provide medicine during his life now offers a "state honour" at his funeral.

### *Sahaityaik Diip (A Literary Lamp), Shraddhanjali (Tribute), and Bhagwati Vandanaa (Devotional Hymn)*

Three poems in the devotional-elegiac mode. Saahityaik Diip mourns the passing of Prabhash Choudhary, editor of Mithila Mihir, using the metaphor of a lamp that burns without ghee or wick — exhausted, extinguished. Shraddhanjali is an acrostic tribute in which the first letters of each couplet spell the name of the departed. Bhagwati Vandanaa is a conventional devotional hymn with a self-critical quality: the speaker acknowledges personal failings and inadequacies before the goddess.

### *Phagua and Phaguak Premopahaar (Holi Poems)*

Two festive poems on the Holi celebration, employing the traditional dhamar-style rhythm of the phagua genre. Kaniyan Maharaaniik Aarti is a playful bhajan-parody for the Holi season, in which the "kaniyaan maharaani" (the beloved) is addressed with mock-devotional fervour. These poems show Mishra's facility with established folk-lyric forms.

## VIII. NARRATIVE CRAFT AND STYLISTIC FEATURES

Across his essays, stories, and poems, Nabo Narayan Mishra's style is characterised by six distinctive features:

### *1. The Witness Voice*

Mishra writes consistently as a witness — someone who was present, who knew the people involved, who participated in the events described. This witness position gives his essays documentary authority and his stories autobiographical warmth. The cost is occasional sacrificing of aesthetic distance: essays sometimes read as reports rather than critical assessments. But the authenticity of the witness voice is undeniable.

### *2. Chronological Discipline*

Both his interviews and his institutional essays follow a strict chronological order. He moves from the subject's arrival in Kolkata, through their engagement with the Maithili movement, to their specific contributions, to their current situation or posthumous legacy. This chronological discipline produces clarity and coherence, though it limits the analytical depth that a more thematic organisation might achieve.

### *3. Oral Register*

His prose has a strong oral quality: the rhythms of Maithili speech, the use of direct address, the frequent invocation of remembered conversations. His stories in particular are narrated in a voice close to that of a skilled Maithili storyteller (kathakar), with the warmth and immediacy of oral narration. This oral register connects his work to the folk narrative tradition that Maithili literature has always valued.

### *4. Ethical Seriousness*

Running through all his writing is a consistent ethical seriousness: concern for the treatment of elders and predecessors, anger at ingratitude and arrogance, admiration for self-sacrifice and community service, anxiety about the survival of Maithili language and culture. This ethical seriousness gives his work coherence and purpose, even when individual pieces are slight.

### *5. Institutional Consciousness*

Unlike many creative writers, Mishra has a strong sense of literary institutions: how organisations are founded and sustained, what makes a journal last, why some cultural initiatives succeed and others fail. This institutional consciousness makes his essays valuable primary sources for the history of Maithili literature in Kolkata and Bihar.

### *6. Elegy as Dominant Mode*

Both his poetry and his essays return repeatedly to elegy — the mourning of departed friends and mentors, the anxiety about the survival of a literary tradition, the sense that a golden era has passed. This elegiac consciousness shapes the Samagra as a whole: it is a work of memory and tribute, a document of a generation's literary activism now passing into history.

# IX. WESTERN CRITICAL PERSPECTIVES

## IX.A New Criticism and Formalism

New Criticism (Cleanth Brooks, Robert Penn Warren) insists on close reading of the literary text as an autonomous artefact, attending to its internal structure, imagery, tension, and resolution. Applied to Mishra's stories, New Critical analysis reveals varying degrees of formal achievement. In "Ekata Pakal Aam," the single ripe mango functions as a resonant symbol of scarcity and sharing; the five-year-old's request to include the cousin is a formally elegant resolution of the story's central ethical proposition. In "Yugadharma," the winter cold functions as an objective correlative (in T. S. Eliot's sense) for Lalbihhari's emotional state — his numbness, his abandonment, his withdrawal from the communal warmth he once generated.

However, many of Mishra's stories fall short by New Critical standards: they are too explicitly didactic (the moral is stated rather than embodied), characters are insufficiently individualised (the arrogant Badri Babu in "Ghamandak Phal" is a type rather than a person), and structural resolution is often achieved through coincidence or sentiment rather than internal necessity. The essays, as non-fiction, lie outside New Criticism's primary domain, but the poems show some capacity for the controlled tension and resolution that New Criticism values — especially in the elegies, where the tension between loss and tribute is productively sustained.

## IX.B Structuralism and Narratology

Applying Gerard Genette's narratological framework: Mishra's stories are predominantly homodiegetic or autodiegetic — the narrator is either a participant in or the protagonist of the story. This choice of narrative position suits the witness voice but limits narrative flexibility. The stories rarely employ the kind of complex temporal manipulation (analepsis, prolepsis) that marks sophisticated modern fiction; they are predominantly linear, moving from situation through complication to resolution.

Vladimir Propp's morphology of the folktale is relevant: several stories follow the Proppian sequence with remarkable fidelity — initial equilibrium, disruption, complication, resolution, and restoration. "Ghamandak Phal" is almost a textbook Proppian structure. This folk-tale morphology is not a weakness — it reflects Mishra's deep roots in the oral storytelling tradition — but it does constrain the stories' capacity for the kind of ambiguity and open-endedness that characterises modernist fiction.

## IX.C Postcolonial and Subaltern Theory

The Samagra is deeply postcolonial in its cultural politics: its subject is the struggle of Maithili — a language marginalised by Hindi nationalism and Sanskritised Brahminism alike — to claim recognition, representation, and institutional support. The interviews with Kishorikant Mishra and Virendra Mallick are primary documents of this struggle: the census agitation, the Sahitya Akademi recognition, the Eighth Schedule inclusion, the internal politics of literary organisations.

Virendra Mallick's observation — that Maithili literary organisations are dominated by Brahmins and Kayasthas, with negligible Dalit participation — is an important critique that Mishra records without distancing himself from it. This critical consciousness aligns with the subaltern studies tradition initiated by Ranajit Guha and extended by Gayatri Spivak. Mishra himself, though not from a Dalit background, demonstrates in his writing a consistent concern for the excluded and overlooked: the migrant worker (in "Yatraak Feri"), the selfless elder brother (in "Yugadharma"), the unrecognised cultural servant (in the essay on Pitambar Pathak).

## IX.D Marxist and Sociological Criticism

Mishra's politics are clearly left-leaning, shaped by the Kolkata cultural milieu of the 1970s-80s where Marxism and the Naxalite movement

were powerful intellectual forces. Virendra Mallick's interview documents this explicitly: Marxism, then Maoism, then a qualified disillusionment. Mishra's Navageet is explicitly a protest song against corruption and political cynicism. His stories show solidarity with the exploited: the migrant worker trapped by an unsympathetic employer, the selfless brother abandoned by the siblings he raised.

A Lukácsian analysis (Georg Lukács's theory of realism) would find in Mishra's best stories — "Yugadharma" above all — a creditable attempt at typification: Lalbihhari as a representative figure whose individual fate illuminates broader social contradictions. The story avoids both sentimental romanticisation and naturalist pessimism; it presents, with restraint, the human cost of social transformation.

# X. INDIAN CRITICAL PERSPECTIVES

## X.A Rasa Theory (Bharata and Abhinavagupta)

The Natyashastra of Bharata (c. 2nd century BCE) identifies eight primary rasas (emotional essences) that literary art can produce in its audience: shringara (love), vira (heroism), karuna (compassion), adbhuta (wonder), hasya (comedy), bhayanaka (fear), bibhatsa (disgust), and raudra (fury). Abhinavagupta (c. 1000 CE), in the Abhinavabharati, adds shanta (tranquillity) as a ninth rasa and deepens the theory by arguing that rasa is not merely the representation of emotion but its transformation through the aesthetic medium into a universal, impersonal experience (saadharanikaran).

In Mishra's Samagra, karuna (compassion/pathos) is the dominant rasa, especially in the elegies, the memorial essays, and stories like "Yugadharma." Hasya (comedy) tempered by social observation marks "Ehno Hoit Chhai." Vira (heroism) is present in the essays on Pitambar Pathak and the Maithili movement activists — heroes not of the battlefield but of cultural resistance. Shringara appears, gently, in the Holi poems and the marriage stories. Shanta (tranquillity) is the rasa toward which the elegies ultimately move — not consolation exactly, but the acceptance of loss as part of the cosmic order (as the Shanti Mantra opening the book itself enacts).

## X.B Dhvani Theory (Anandavardhana)

Anandavardhana (c. 850 CE) in the Dhvanyaloka argues that the highest poetry operates through dhvani — resonance or suggestion — where

the unstated meaning is more powerful than the stated. The poem "Nav Varshaak Sandarbh Me" works by dhvani: the New Year celebration, normally a time of joy, is charged with grief for the departed "Lalit Babu" without this grief ever being stated as such. The festive occasion becomes the site of personal mourning, and this contrast creates the dhvani. Similarly, in "Prithviik Bhaar," the cataloguing of Maithili's institutional failures speaks, by dhvani, to the sacrifices of those who have given their lives to the language.

In the stories, dhvani is less consistently deployed. "Ekata Pakal Aam" achieves a degree of dhvani: the single ripe mango suggests, without stating, the scarcity and sharing ethics of the Maithili village world. "Yugadharma's" winter cold resonates with more than meteorological significance. But many stories remain at the level of explicit statement, sacrificing dhvani for direct moral articulation.

## X.C The Navya Nyaya Epistemological Framework of Gangesa Upadhyaya

Gangesa Upadhyaya (c. 1325 CE) of Mithila — the same region that produced Mishra — founded the Navya Nyaya (New Logic) school with his masterwork Tattvachintamani (Jewel of Reflection on the Truth). Divided into four chapters treating the four pramanas (valid sources of knowledge) — pratyaksha (perception), anumana (inference), upamana (comparison), and shabda (testimony/verbal authority) — the Tattvachintamani provides the most rigorous Indian epistemological framework ever developed.

Gangesa's epistemology insists that all cognition is relational — structured by the visheshana-visheshya (qualifier-qualificand) relation. We know a thing not as an isolated object but as qualified by attributes and situated in a network of relations. This relational epistemology, applied to literary analysis, asks: how does the text produce knowledge? Through what cognitive structures? And how does the reader come to know (or believe they know) the textual world?

### *Pratyaksha (Perception) Applied to Mishra*

Gangesa distinguishes nirvikalpaka pratyaksha (non-conceptual, pure sensory awareness before categorisation) from savikalpaka pratyaksha (conceptual perception, already structured by categories). Mishra's prose operates almost entirely in savikalpaka mode — his descriptions of the Mahajati Sadan audience, the winter cold in "Yugadharma," the ripe mango, are already conceptually organised, already saturated with cultural meaning. But

his best passages reach toward the nirvikalpaka: the smell of rain in the journey story, the precise body language of Lalbihhari huddled by the fire, the specific quality of Thakur's handshake at their final meeting. These moments of near-perceptual vividness are where Mishra's prose is most alive.

Gangesa's analysis of perceptual error (bhrama) is relevant to Mishra's essays on institutional history, where he shows how organisations and individuals are systematically misperceived — Virendra Mallick seen as a "casteist," Kokil Manch excluded from a national seminar it helped to build. Mishra's essays function as corrections of such bhrama, offering the witness's testimony to restore accurate perception.

### *Anumana (Inference) Applied to Mishra*

For Gangesa, valid inference requires a vyapti — a reliable pervasive relation between the inferential mark (hetu) and the inferred conclusion (sadhya). In Mishra's stories, characters reason inferentially — and often fallaciously — about each other. Badri Babu infers his own superiority from his education; the villagers infer Lalbihhari's happiness from his social success. These are hetvabhasas (pseudo-inferences): the pervasion does not hold. Education does not imply superiority; social success does not imply happiness. Mishra's stories expose these fallacious vyaptis, showing the human costs of reasoning from unreliable general rules.

Gangesa's distinction between valid and invalid inference is precisely the distinction Mishra's social realism exploits: the gap between how things appear (the fallacious inference) and how they are (the corrective perception offered by the story).

### *Upamana (Comparison) Applied to Mishra*

Upamana — knowledge through comparison and analogy — is Mishra's central critical instrument as an essayist. His essays consistently work by comparison: Ramlochan Thakur is compared to an icon and an encyclopedia; Prabhash Choudhary is compared to a lamp burning without oil; Maithili literature is compared to a fire that periodically blazes and then subsides. These comparisons (upamanas) are not mere ornament; they constitute the cognitive structure by which Mishra arrives at his evaluations. The lamp-without-oil image for Prabhash Choudhary is an upamana that captures both his exhaustion and his continuing luminosity — a richer cognition than any direct description could achieve.

### *Shabda (Testimony) Applied to Mishra*

For Gangesa, shabda — verbal testimony — is a valid pramana when it comes from an apta (reliable, truthful speaker). The entire Samagra rests on the epistemic claim that Mishra is an apta — that his testimony about literary figures, events, and institutions is reliable because he was present, because he participated, because he knew the people involved personally. The interviews are shabda-based cognition: the testimony of Kishorikant Mishra, Ramlochan Thakur, and Virendra Mallick, transmitted through Mishra's questions and framing, as valid testimony about Maithili literary history.

Gangesa's conditions for valid shabda include the reliability of the speaker and the absence of defect (dosha) in the transmission. Mishra's editorial preface acknowledges the possibility of incompleteness (much was "scattered in various periodicals") and partial recovery (he collected "as much as could be sent and preserved"). This honest acknowledgment of the limits of testimony is itself a Navya Nyaya-aligned epistemic virtue: cognising one's own limitations as a means of avoiding overconfident claims.

### *The Visheshana-Visheshya (Qualifier-Qualificand) Structure in Mishra's Characters*

Gangesa's most technically refined contribution is the analysis of cognition as structured by the qualifier-qualificand relation: we know Lalbihhari not as an abstract figure but as qualified by his role as eldest brother, his sacrifices, his social reputation, his current abandonment, his physical position huddled by the fire. These qualifiers constitute what Lalbihhari is, epistemologically speaking. Mishra's characterisation — especially in "Yugadharma" — is instinctively Navya Nyaya in structure: characters are known through their relational and social qualifiers rather than through psychological depth. This reflects both a limitation (insufficient interiority) and an insight (the social embeddedness of human identity).

## XI. NABO NARAYAN MISHRA IN THE MAITHILI LITERARY CONTEXT

Nabo Narayan Mishra belongs to the generation of Maithili writers who came of literary age in Kolkata in the 1980s, alongside Ramlochan Thakur (poet and playwright), Lakshman Jha Sagar (multi-genre writer), Rajanandan Lal Das (editor and playwright), and Sumangshu Shekhar Choudhary (playwright and editor). This generation was formed by the Maithili movement

— the struggle for Eighth Schedule recognition — and by the leftist intellectual culture of Kolkata, which inflected Maithili writing with socialist values and a concern for the marginalised.

Within this generational context, Mishra occupies a specific niche: the activist-writer rather than the primary creative writer. He is more productive as an essayist and memoirist than as a fiction writer or poet, more valuable as an institutional historian than as an aesthetic experimenter. His stories are earnest and socially engaged but do not achieve the psychological complexity of Ramlochan Thakur's poetry or the satirical edge of the best Maithili comic tradition (represented by Harimohan Jha's Khattar Kaka). His poems are sincere and formally competent but do not aspire to the innovation of Nagarjun/Yatri, whom he explicitly reveres.

What makes Mishra distinctive — and valuable — is precisely what makes him unusual: his sustained, two-decade engagement with Kokil Manch, his meticulous recording of institutional history, his preservation of the testimony of mentors and contemporaries, and his willingness to be a secondary figure — a secretary, an organiser, a witness — in service of a larger cultural cause. In Maithili literary culture, where primary creative work attracts the lion's share of critical attention, Mishra's Samagra is a reminder of the indispensable work of cultural preservation.

The editor Ashish Anichhinhar's comparison is apt: of Kolkata-based Maithili writers, on a proportional basis, Mishra has written more about Kolkata and its Maithili cultural life than anyone else. The Samagra makes this scattered testimony legible as a coherent archive.

## XII. CRITICAL ASSESSMENT: STRENGTHS AND LIMITATIONS

### Strengths

The documentary and testimonial value of the Samagra is high. The interviews with Kishorikant Mishra, Ramlochan Thakur, and Virendra Mallick are primary sources of considerable importance for the history of the Maithili movement in Kolkata and Bihar. The institutional essays — on Kokil Manch, Mithila Vikas Parishad, Mithila Darshan, Mithila Mihir, Samparak — constitute the fullest account available of Kolkata's Maithili cultural infrastructure. The theatrical record in "Maithili Rangmanch aur Kolkata" is invaluable.

The stories show a genuine talent for social observation and an ear for Maithili spoken dialogue. "Yugadharma" demonstrates structural command and emotional restraint. "Ekata Pakal Aam" achieves its modest effect through economy. The Holi poems and the devotional hymns show facility with traditional folk-lyric forms. The elegies are sincere and, at their best, formally controlled.

The ethical consistency of the work is also a strength: across all genres, Mishra maintains a coherent set of values — solidarity with the overlooked, gratitude toward mentors, commitment to cultural service — that gives the Samagra its moral texture.

### Limitations

As a creative writer, Mishra's limitations are significant. His stories are predominantly moral allegories rather than psychologically complex fiction: characters are types (the arrogant government servant, the selfless eldest brother, the irascible but good-natured Mohanji) rather than individuals. Narrative structure is frequently formulaic. Psychological interiority is superficial. The stories rarely challenge the reader's assumptions or generate the productive ambiguity that marks major fiction.

His poetry, while competent and sincere, does not reach the aesthetic distinction of the best Maithili lyric tradition. It lacks the dhvani-density of Ramlochan Thakur's verse or the formal innovation of Nagarjun. The navageet is technically competent but rhetorical rather than resonant.

The essays, while documentarily valuable, are often more celebratory than critical. Mishra writes about figures he admires, and his admiration sometimes overwhelms his analytical capacity. A more critical assessment of, say, the internal politics of Kokil Manch or the ideological limitations of the Maithili movement's leadership would be more demanding but also more illuminating.

## XIII. CONCLUSION

Nabo Narayan Mishra's Samagra is, above all, an act of cultural memory. It gathers the scattered creative and documentary output of a lifetime spent in service of Maithili language and culture — as an activist, as a theatrical organiser, as an interviewer, as an essayist, and as a storyteller and poet. Its primary value is testimonial: it preserves the voices of a generation of Maithili cultural workers (Ramlochan Thakur, Kishorikant Mishra, Virendra Mallick,

Rajanandan Lal Das, Prabodh Narayan Singh, Pitambar Pathak) and reconstructs the institutional history of the Maithili movement in Kolkata.

Assessed against Western critical frameworks, the Samagra is a mixed achievement: some stories and poems of genuine quality, a body of essays of considerable documentary value, and a consistent ethical seriousness that gives the whole work moral coherence. Against Indian critical frameworks, the dominant rasa is karuna (compassion), deepened by shanta (tranquillity) in the elegies, and the dhvani of the best pieces resonates beyond their explicit statements.

The Navya Nyaya framework of Gangesa Upadhyaya — born, like Mishra, in Mithila — provides perhaps the most illuminating critical lens. Mishra's writing is fundamentally testimonial: it proceeds by pratyaksha (the witness's perception), by anumana (the inference from what he observed to what it means), by upamana (the comparison that illuminates), and by shabda (the testimony he transmits and the testimony he records). His characters and institutional figures are known through their visheshana (social qualifiers) rather than through psychological depth — a relational epistemology that reflects both his cultural world and his aesthetic instincts.

The Samagra is dedicated to "Srijanhaar" — the Creator. It is itself a creative act: the creation of an archive that would otherwise not exist. For Maithili literary history, and for anyone seeking to understand the cultural life of the Mithila diaspora in Kolkata across the late twentieth and early twenty-first centuries, Nabo Narayan Mishra's Samagra is an indispensable resource.

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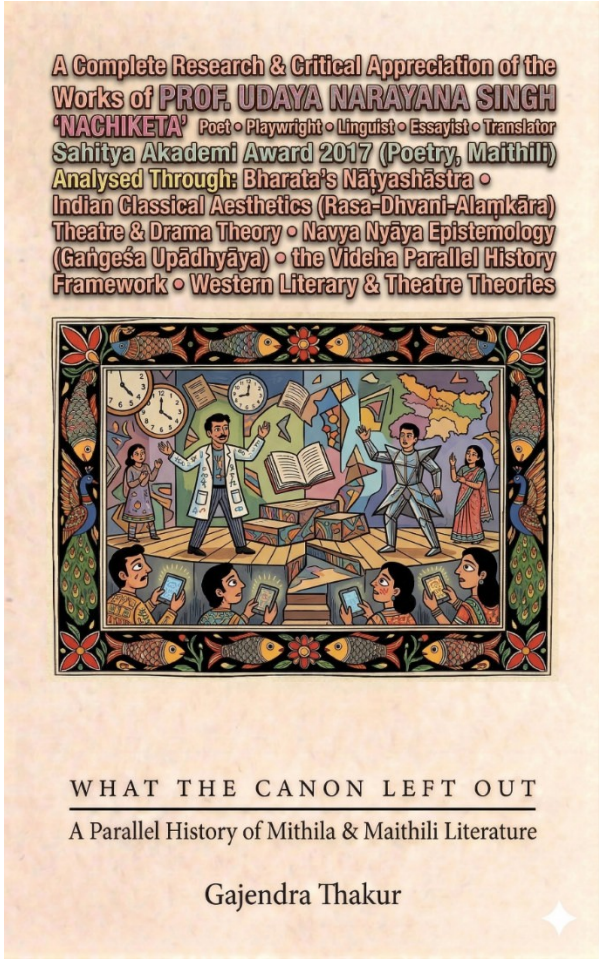


## *A Complete Research & Critical Appreciation of the Works of*

**PROF. UDAYA NARAYANA SINGH**

**'NACHIKETA'**

*Poet • Playwright • Linguist • Essayist • Translator*

**Sahitya Akademi Award 2017 (Poetry, Maithili)**

*Analysed Through: Bharata's Nāṭyashāstra • Indian Classical Aesthetics (Rasa-Dhvani-Alaṃkāra) • Theatre & Drama Theory • Navya Nyāya Epistemology (Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya) • the Videha Parallel History Framework • Western Literary & Theatre Theories*

# I. INTRODUCTION

Professor Udaya Narayana Singh 'Nachiketa' stands as one of the most remarkable literary personalities in contemporary Indian literature. Poet, playwright, linguist, essayist, translator, editor, documentary filmmaker, academic administrator, and language-policy architect — his life and work constitute a singular convergence of scientific rigour and artistic creativity that is rare in any literature, and exceptional in the history of Maithili letters. Born on 23 November 1951 in Calcutta, the son of two Hindi scholars — his father Prabodh Narayan Singh a Maithili speaker from Saharsa, North Bihar, and his mother Anima Singh a Bengali speaker from Mymensingh (now Bangladesh) — Nachiketa is, in the deepest biological and cultural sense, a "grassroots bilingual," inheriting two of the great literary traditions of eastern India simultaneously.

His pen name 'Nachiketa' is taken from the ancient Vedic myth preserved in the Kaṭhopanishad: the young boy Nachiketa who, sent to the abode of Death (Yama) by his angry father, refuses to be distracted by the material temptations Yama offers him, insisting instead on the ultimate philosophical question — What happens after death? What is the Self? — and ultimately receives the secret knowledge of the immortal Ātmān. The pen name thus encodes the author's fundamental literary stance: an unflinching intellectual and spiritual quest that refuses the comfortable and the conventional, pressing towards the unnamed and the unnameable.

This report provides a complete research and critical appreciation of Nachiketa's works — the full archive of which is available at www.videha.co.in/pothi.htm — through an integrated set of analytical frameworks: Bharata's Nāṭyashāstra and its dramaturgy; classical Indian aesthetics (Rasa, Dhvani, Alaṃkāra); the Navya Nyāya epistemological

tradition of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya; the Videha Parallel History Framework (Gajendra Thakur); Western theatre and drama theory (Aristotle, Brecht, Artaud, Grotowski, Peter Brook); and post-colonial literary criticism. The analysis draws on all fourteen files provided: plays, poetry collections, journals (Mithila Darshan), and the multi-lingual Nachiketa Vividh compendium.

# II. BIOGRAPHICAL & SCHOLARLY CONTEXT

## 2.1 Formation and Education

Nachiketa's intellectual formation is of exceptional breadth. Educated first in the traditional Sanskrit Tol (gurukul-style paṭhashālā) as well as at the Sanskrit College, Calcutta, he proceeded to study Linguistics (Hons.) at Calcutta (1969–72, designated Eshan Scholar), then to a Master's degree at the University of Delhi (1972–74, Uggersain Memorial Gold Medal), followed by a semester at the University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign with an LSA (Linguistic Society of America) Fellowship (1978), and a Ph.D. in Linguistics (Syntax and Semantics) from the University of Delhi in 1979. His subsequent career took him through teaching posts at the Universities of MSU-Baroda (1979–81), South Gujarat/Surat (1981–85), Delhi (1985–87), and Hyderabad (1987–2000), before the two defining institutional posts: Director of the Central Institute of Indian Languages (CIIL), Mysore (2000–2009), and Pro-Vice-Chancellor (first ever) of Visva-Bharati, Santiniketan (2010–2012). He is currently Chair-Professor and Dean, Faculty of Arts, Amity Centre for Linguistic Studies (ACLiS), Amity University Haryana, Gurgaon.

At CIIL, Nachiketa set up three transformative national linguistic infrastructure institutions: the National Translation Mission (NTM), the Linguistic Data Consortium for Indian Languages (LDC-IL), and the National Testing Service (NTS). He also established the Centre for Applied Linguistics and Translation Studies (CALTS) at the University of Hyderabad. He has visited and lectured in Bangladesh, Caribbean, France, Germany, Italy, Nepal, Pakistan, Russia, Singapore, Sweden, Thailand, USA, Andorra, Scotland and China — and has been a poet-invitee at the Frankfurt Book Fair (India Guest of Honour, 2006).

## 2.2 Literary Output: Overview

Nachiketa's literary output is vast, multilingual, and multi-generic:

| Category | Language | Count/Details |
|---|---|---|
| Poetry Collections | Maithili | 7 collections (1966–2015), incl. award-winning Jahalak Diary (2015) |
| Poetry Collections | Bengali | 4 collections (1987–2011) |
| Poetry Collections | English | Second Person Singular (tr. from Maithili, 2005) |
| Plays | Maithili | 12 plays (1971–2008), ranging from full-length to one-acts |
| Literary Essays | Bengali & English | 6 books of literary essays |
| Short Stories | Bengali | 1 collection; children's fiction |
| Translations | Multiple directions | Tagore's complete children's literature (Bangla → Maithili); Vachana poems (Kannada → Maithili); The Original Gitanjali (2013) |
| Academic Works | English | 250+ research papers; 16 edited volumes |
| Documentaries | Multiple languages | 545 documentary films on Indian languages & cultures |
| Total Books | All languages | 56+ books |

### 2.3 Awards and Honours

The constellation of awards Nachiketa has received is itself testimony to his standing across multiple disciplines:

- Sahitya Akademi Award for Poetry 2017 — for Jahalak Diary (Maithili)
- Keertinarayan Mishra Award (Chetana Samiti, 2009) — for the play No Entry: Mā Pravisha (presented by the Chief Minister of Bihar, 31 October 2009)
- Mithila Vibhuti Sanman 2007
- Jyotirishwar Sanman 2016 — for lifetime contribution to Maithili theatre (Mailorang, New Delhi)
- Sir Ganganath Jha Sanman 2016 — for contributions to Maithili Literature
- Prof. Suniti Kumar Chatterji National Lectureship, The Asiatic Society, Kolkata (2015)
- Kalaignar Porkizhi Award, BAPASI, Chennai (2014)
- UGC Research Fellowship (1974–78); LSA Fellowship, University of Illinois (1978); UNESCO Research Associateship (1979); PICL Fellowship, Humboldt University, Berlin (1985)
- Uggersain Memorial Gold Medal, University of Delhi (1974)
- Eshan Scholar, Calcutta University

## III. THE DRAMATIC WORKS: SURVEY AND ANALYSIS

### 3.1 The Playwright’s Arc: Twelve Plays Across Four Decades

Nachiketa’s career as a playwright spans from 1971 to 2008, encompassing twelve plays that chart both his personal artistic evolution and the development of modern Maithili theatre. The twelve plays are:

| Year | Title | Genre/Type | Publisher/Notes |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1971 | Nāyakak Nām Jīvan | Full play | Akhil Bharatiya Mithila Sangh, Calcutta. 112 pp. (The Hero is Life) |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1974 | Ek Chhal Rājā | Full play | Maithili Rangamancha, Calcutta. 72 pp. (There Was a King) |
| 1974 | Nāṭakak Lel | Full play | Mithila Darshan, Calcutta. iv+76 pp. (For a Play) |
| 1976 | Pratyavartan | Full play | Mithila Darshan, Calcutta. 59 pp. (The Return) |
| 1977 | Andolan | Full play | Mithila Darshan, Calcutta. 45 pp. (The Movement) |
| 1977 | Rāmlīlā | Full play | Mithila Darshan, Calcutta. 48 pp. (The Ramlila) |
| 1978 | Janak Ā’ Anya Ekāṅkī | One-act plays | Mithila Darshan, Calcutta. (Janak and Other One-Acts) |
| 1988 | Priyamvadā | Natika | Major dramatic work |
| 1988 | Andolan | Revised edition | Mithila Darshan |
| 2008 | No Entry: Mā Pravish | Full play | Shruti Publications, Delhi. ISBN 978-81-907729-0-7; award-winning |
| -- | (Two further plays) | Manuscripts/e-zine | Including Videha-serialised works |

## 3.2 Nayakak Nam Jivan (1971): The Hero is Life

Nachiketa's debut play, written when he was nineteen or twenty, already reveals the philosophical preoccupations that will define his entire dramatic career. The title — Nāyakak Nām Jīvan, "The Hero's Name is Life" — is itself a programmatic statement. The hero (nāyaka) in the Natyashastra tradition is defined by specific qualities: modesty (vineeta), sweetness of temper (madhura), sacrifice (tyāgi), capability (daksha), noble lineage, and moral integrity. By naming Life itself as the hero, Nachiketa performs a philosophical inversion: the traditional nāyaka is de-individuated, and Life-as-collective-experience takes the protagonist position.

This gesture is simultaneously in dialogue with the Western existentialist theatre tradition (Sartre's No Exit, Camus's Caligula) and with the Indian tradition of the abstract or allegorical hero found in Sanskrit nataka. The play engages with the early 1970s political climate of West Bengal and Bihar — the turbulent aftermath of the Naxalite movement, the emergency of political violence — filtered through the sensibility of a young bilingual intellectual formed simultaneously in Calcutta's literary culture and in the Maithili oral tradition.

## 3.3 Ek Chhal Raja (1974): There Was a King

Written in the same year as Nāṭakak Lel, Ek Chhal Rājā ("There Was a King") draws on the archetype of the flawed ruler. The title's use of chhal (deceit, treachery) is central: this is not a king who merely fails, but one defined by his fundamental deceptiveness. In the Nāṭyashāstra framework, the nāyaka must be dharmika — morally upright — but Nachiketa's play makes the protagonist a rāja whose identity is constituted by his very unrighteousness. This inverts the classical convention even as it uses its vocabulary.

The play participates in a broader Maithili theatrical tradition engaging with the legend of King Janak, but pivots it toward political allegory. The folktale-opening formula "there was a king" ("Ek chhal rājā") instantly signals both the traditional folk-narrative register and, through the irony of its political application, the contemporary critique of power.

## 3.4 Natak Ka Lel (1974): For a Play / For the Sake of Drama

Nāṭakak Lel is a metatheaterical work in the tradition of plays-about-plays — Pirandello's Six Characters in Search of an Author, Anouilh's Antigone, Brecht's The Caucasian Chalk Circle with its embedded storyteller — but

grounded entirely in Maithili theatrical aesthetics. The title's ambiguity is deliberate: lel means both "for the sake of" and "for the purpose/benefit of," so the title reads simultaneously as "For a Play" (i.e., "This exists for the sake of drama") and as an imperative: "Take it for a play." This Brechtian double-gesture — making visible the theatrical apparatus while demanding emotional engagement — establishes Nachiketa as a playwright aware of both Indian and European theatrical modernism.

### 3.5 Pratyavartan (1976): The Return

Pratyavartan ("The Return") engages with one of the oldest archetypes in world drama: the nostos, the homecoming. From the Odyssey through Chekhov's Three Sisters to Pinter's The Homecoming, the drama of return — the collision between the memory of home and the reality found upon return — has been a perennial source of theatrical tension. In the Maithili context, Pratyavartan resonates with the specific experience of the Maithili diaspora: the millions who have left the Mithila region for Calcutta, Delhi, Bombay, and beyond, and who return to find a home transformed beyond recognition or recognition transformed beyond home.

The play is written with thirty-three sanchari bhavas (transitory emotional states) operating simultaneously — the complexity of homecoming admits no single dominant emotional register. This is a dramaturgical choice consistent with the Nāṭyashāstra's understanding that the richest aesthetic experience involves the orchestration of multiple transitory emotions around a stable sthāyibhāva (permanent emotion).

### 3.6 Andolan (1977): The Movement

Andolan ("The Movement") is the most overtly political of the early plays. Written in the context of the Emergency (1975–77) and its aftermath, the play engages with the question of political resistance — andolan in Hindi-Maithili means simultaneously a "movement" (political), a "vibration" or "oscillation" (physical), and a "waving" (as of a flag). These polysemic possibilities are exploited throughout: the political movement of the title is simultaneously a physical movement of bodies through space, and a vibration — the trembling of the oppressed, the quaking of power.

In the Natyashastra framework, this play deploys primarily the Ārabhaṭī vritti — the vigorous mode of expression associated with valor, conflict, and political confrontation. The Rudra rasa (anger) and Vīra rasa (heroism) dominate, with

Karunā rasa (compassion) providing the emotional undertow for the suffering of those crushed by the system.

## 3.7 Ramlila (1977): The Ramlila

Rāmlīlā is Nachiketa's most explicitly mythological play. The Ramlila — the performative re-enactment of the Ramayana narrative — is itself a theatrical tradition within a theatrical tradition, a meta-performance in which the performers know they are performing a performance. Nachiketa exploits this layered structure to interrogate the relationship between myth and contemporary reality, between the idealized world of the epics and the compromised world of political and social life in post-Independence India.

The play is particularly interesting in the context of the Nāṭyashāstra, which itself draws its authority partly from Vedic ritual and Ramayana-based dramatic traditions. Nāṭyashāstra Chapter I describes how Brahma composed the Nāṭaveda precisely to provide the masses with access to the wisdom of the Vedas through the medium of visible and audible performance. Rāmlīlā literalises this: it IS the fifth Veda in action, and Nachiketa's play-about-Ramlila interrogates the status of that fifth Veda in modern Mithila.

## 3.8 Janak a Anya Ekankee (1978): Janak and Other One-Acts

The collection of one-act plays (ekāṅkī) centred on the figure of Janak — the philosopher-king of Videha (Mithila), father of Sita — is perhaps Nachiketa's most direct engagement with the Maithili cultural inheritance. Janak is the ideal raja-rishi (royal sage), the figure who combines kingly power with philosophical dispassion and wisdom. His famous declaration of janaka-videhatva — his complete non-attachment to his kingdom, his position, his identity — makes him the perfect embodiment of the Navya Nyaya ideal of cognition unclouded by personal interest.

In dramaturgical terms, the Janak plays represent Nachiketa's most sustained experiment with the Nāṭyashāstra's ten dramatic forms (daśarūpa). The ekāṅkī form itself (one-act play) has no precise Nāṭyashāstra equivalent, but participates in the Indian tradition of the vīthī and ānkiyā (short dramatic forms). Nachiketa's deployment of Janak across multiple short forms rather than a single long nataka suggests a fragmented, prismatic approach to the myth — seeing it from multiple angles simultaneously, as the Navya Nyaya technique of anumana requires.

## 3.9 Priyamvada (1988): The One Who Speaks Pleasingly

Priyamvadā — "One who speaks in sweet/agreeable words" (Sanskrit priya + vadā) — is both a character-name from the Sanskrit tradition (she is Shakuntala's companion in Kālidāsa's Abhijnana-Shakuntalam, defined by her gentle, agreeable speech) and a quality prescribed for the ideal dramatic heroine by Bharata Muni. The Nāṭyashāstra defines the nāyikā (heroine) as among her qualities priyamvadā — one who speaks pleasingly (N.S. XXIV). By choosing this as his play's title, Nachiketa opens an intertextual dialogue with both the Sanskrit dramatic tradition and Kālidāsa's greatest play.

Priyamvadā is a natika (short play or natikaa) in form — a genre defined by Bharata as a play with a single act, a happy outcome, and themes drawn from real life. It is Nachiketa's most concentrated experiment with the Sanskrit dramatic conventions, while simultaneously deploying them in a contemporary Maithili social context. The play's dramatic conflict centres on the disjunction between the sweet language prescribed for women by social convention and the harsh realities of their actual experience — making priyamvada itself the site of ideological contestation.

## 3.10 No Entry: Ma Pravish (2008): The Landmark Play

No Entry: Mā Pravish is Nachiketa's most celebrated theatrical achievement, winner of the Keertinarayan Mishra Award (2009), first serialised in the Videha eJournal in 2008 (reaching 15,000 readers online), and published in book form by Shruti Publications, Delhi. Its bilingual English/Maithili title encodes its central dramatic strategy: the play's governing metaphor is the "No Entry" traffic sign — ubiquitous in Indian urban spaces — which Nachiketa reads as the fundamental metaphor for all the prohibitions, exclusions, and denied accesses that constitute oppressive social, linguistic, and political structures.

The dedication — to the fifteen thousand readers who read the play online "week by week" with great enthusiasm, and to the countless others who will read it and perform it — reflects the play's radical innovation in terms of distribution. No Entry was, as the introduction by Gajendra Thakur notes, a landmark: the first major Maithili play to be published first in digital form through an e-zine, reaching an audience of diaspora Maithilis worldwide before any print edition.

The play premiered on stage in Patna on 21 February 2011 (Maithili Day / International Mother Language Day), a date whose symbolic resonance is exact: the play about language, exclusion, and cultural rights premiered on the

day dedicated globally to the celebration and protection of mother-tongue languages.

Thematically, No Entry: Mā Pravish deploys the “No Entry” sign across multiple registers simultaneously: the exclusion of Maithili from official spaces and institutions (language rights); the exclusion of women from public discourse (gender); the exclusion of the poor from opportunities (class); the exclusion of marginal communities from cultural citizenship (caste and region). The play is thus simultaneously a linguistic manifesto, a feminist critique, a class analysis, and a cultural rights document — all dramatised through the specifically Maithili theatrical idiom.

> *"No Entry" — the most common prohibition sign in post-liberalisation India. When does it apply to language? When does it prohibit the mother? When does "Ma Pravish" (Enter, Mother) become the counter-sign of cultural resistance? — Nachiketa, No Entry: Ma Pravish (2008)*

# IV. THE POETIC WORKS

## 4.1 Poetry Collections: Chronological Survey

Nachiketa’s seven Maithili poetry collections span sixty years of creative life:

| Year | Title | Publisher | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1966 | Kavayo Vadanti | Mithila Darshan, Calcutta | Debut: published at age 15. Mythological backdrop, introspective. |
| 1971 | Amrtasya Putrah | Lok Sahitya Parishad, Calcutta | Multiply nested; language becomes self-reflective theme. Love as major motif. |
| 1981 | Anuttaran | Mithila | Political, post- |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | Darshan, Calcutta | Emergency reflections; gender and power. |
| 2005 | Madhyampurush Ekvachan | Vani Prakashan, New Delhi | Major collection; translated into English as Second Person Singular (Katha, 2005) |
| 2005 | Second Person Singular | Katha, New Delhi | English translation with Rizio Yohannan Raj |
| c.2015 | Jahalak Diary | -- | Sahitya Akademi Award 2017 winner. "Jahalak" = sudden flash/insight. |

## 4.2 Kavayo Vadanti (1966): Seers Speak

The debut collection — published when Nachiketa was barely fifteen, though sources variously say fifteen or sixteen — bears a Sanskrit title meaning “The Seers Speak” or “Poets Proclaim.” The title participates in the oldest Indian understanding of the poet (kavi) as seer (rishi), not merely maker. This is the tradition of Veda — where poetry is apaurusheya (not of human origin), revealed to the seer rather than composed by the craftsman. Beginning his poetic career under this ancient authorization, Nachiketa simultaneously claims the full weight of the Maithili and Sanskrit literary inheritance and subjects it to the ironic scrutiny of his adolescent sarcasm.

The collection’s mythological backdrop reflects the influence of his grandparents, who transmitted the oral tradition of the Mithila region — its festivals, its rituals, its narrative repertoire of Maithili folk tale and Puranic legend. This is the collection of someone who has absorbed the tradition before he has begun to critique it.

## 4.3 Madhyampurush Ekvachan (2005): Second Person Singular

The 2005 collection represents the mature Nachiketa: its title, Madhyampurush Ekvachan ("Second Person Singular" in grammatical terminology), is itself a linguistic-philosophical provocation. The second person singular — "you" in its most intimate form — is the pronominal position that establishes the I-Thou relationship that Martin Buber theorized as the site of authentic meeting. By naming his collection "Second Person Singular," Nachiketa positions his poetry as fundamentally relational — always addressed to a "you," always constituted in the space of encounter.

The collection was deemed important enough to be translated into English by the poet in collaboration with Rizio Yohannan Raj (also of Poetry International) and published by Katha in 2005. The English title Second Person Singular retains the grammatical conceit of the Maithili original while making the collection available to the international poetry readership. It was also gifted at the Frankfurt Book Fair 2006 — India Guest of Honour — as part of the presentation of Indian literature to the world.

> *"I speak with restraint; even when I do, I do not use the past tense, I move to an unknown future. I think very little now; even when I do I think in figures of speech. My philosophy aspires for a feeling neither stated nor translated as yet." — Nachiketa, "Old Love" (from Second Person Singular)*

## 4.4 Jahalak Diary (2015): The Sahitya Akademi Award-Winning Collection

Jahalak (झलक) — a Maithili word suggesting a sudden flash, a momentary glimpse, an incandescent spark of perception — is the title of the collection for which Nachiketa received the Sahitya Akademi Award for Maithili Poetry in 2017. The Sahitya Akademi, India's National Academy of Letters, selects its annual awards from books published in the preceding five years; Jahalak Diary thus represents the fullest flowering of Nachiketa's poetic gift, the summation of six decades of writing.

The diary form embedded in the title is significant. The diary is the ultimate first-person genre — intimate, dated, sequential, provisional. But Nachiketa's "diary" is a diary of flashes (jahalak), not of sustained narrative — a poetry of discrete illuminations, each one complete in itself like a sudden opening of light, rather than the continuous autobiographical prose of the traditional diary. This is consonant with the poet's stated aesthetic: "I think very little now; even

when I do, I think in figures of speech." The jahalak is the figure of speech that thinks.

# V. ANALYTICAL FRAMEWORK I: BHARATA'S NATYASHASTRA

## 5.1 Introduction: The Natyashastra and Its Relevance

The Nāṭyashāstra of Bharata Muni (c. 200 BCE – 200 CE) is the foundational treatise of Indian performing arts. Its 36 chapters cover dramatic composition, stagecraft, music, dance, gesture systems, character types, emotional theory, and theatrical aesthetics with encyclopaedic comprehensiveness. Bharata presents the Nāṭyaveda as the "fifth Veda," extracting its four elements from the four existing Vedas: speech (vāk) from the Rigveda, melody (gīta) from the Samaveda, gesture/expression (abhinaya) from the Yajurveda, and aesthetic essence/flavour (rasa) from the Atharvaveda.

The eleven elements Bharata identifies as the essence of natya — Rasa, Bhāva, Abhinaya, Dharmī, Vritti, Pravṛitti, Siddhi, Svara, Ātodya, Gāna, Raṅga — provide an analytical grid for evaluating Nachiketa's theatre that is both historically appropriate (Maithili drama descends from the Sanskrit dramatic tradition) and intellectually productive. Nachiketa himself, trained in Sanskrit from the traditional Tol environment, would have absorbed this tradition before subjecting it to critical revision.

## 5.2 The Rasa Framework Applied to Nachiketa's Drama

The rasa sutra — "Vibhava-anubhava-vyabhichāri-samyogād rasa niṣpattih" ("Rasa is produced from the conjunction of determinants, consequents, and transitory states") — provides the foundational analytical tool. For each of Nachiketa's major plays, the dominant rasa configuration can be identified:

| Play | Dominant Rasa(s) | Sthāyibhāva | Vibhāva (Determinants) | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Nāyakak Nām Jīvan | Vīra + Karūṇa | Utsaha + Shoka | Life's struggle; political | Existentialist |

| | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | | oppression | hero-archetype |
| Ek Chhal Rājā | Rudra + Hāsya | Krodha + Hasa | Deceptive king; corrupt power | Political satire with dark comedy |
| Nāṭakak Lel | Adbhuta + Hāsya | Vismaya + Hasa | Metatheatrical self-revelation | Play-within-play structure |
| Pratyavartan | Karūṇa + Shṃgāra | Shoka + Rati | Return to transformed home; lost love | Nostalgic diaspora emotion |
| Andolan | Vīra + Rudra | Utsaha + Krodha | Political resistance; state violence | Ārabhaṭī vritti dominates |
| Rāmlīlā | Shṃgāra + Śānta | Rati + Sama | Sacred drama; mythological frame | Natyadharmi representation |
| Janak Ekāṅkī | Shṃgāra + Śānta | Rati + Sama | Philosophy-king dialectic | Raja-rishi archetype |
| Priyamvadā | Shṃgāra + Karūṇa | Rati + Shoka | Sweet speech vs. harsh reality | Heroine defined against convention |
| No Entry: Mā Pravish | Rudra + Vīra + Karūṇa | Krodha + Utsaha + Shoka | Language exclusion; gender prohibition; cultural denial | Multi-rasa orchestration |

## 5.3 The Four Vrittis in Nachiketa's Drama

The Nāṭyashāstra identifies four vrittis (modes of expression) that characterise different theatrical styles:

- Bhāratī vritti (verbal/intellectual expression): Dominant in Nāṭakak Lel (the metatheaterical play foregrounds speech and argumentation) and in No Entry: Mā Pravish (where the language-sign is the central dramatic object).
- Śattvatī vritti (emotional/inner expression): Dominant in Pratyavartan and Priyamvadā, where the inner emotional life of characters is the primary dramatic focus.
- Kaiśikī vritti (graceful/aesthetic expression): Present in Rāmlīlā and the Janak ekāṅkī, where beauty and refinement of form are theatrical goals alongside the narrative content.
- Ārabhaṭī vritti (vigorous/conflict expression): Dominant in Andolan and Ek Chhal Rājā, where political confrontation and power struggle drive the dramatic action.

Nachiketa's most sophisticated play, No Entry: Mā Pravish, deploys all four vrittis sequentially and simultaneously — a technical achievement that marks it as the culmination of his dramaturgical development.

## 5.4 Lokadharmi and Natyadharmi

The Nāṭyashāstra distinguishes between natyadharmi (stylised, convention-bound theatrical representation) and lokadharmi (realistic, life-like representation grounded in everyday behaviour). Nachiketa's theatre occupies a productive tension between these two modes. His early plays (the 1970s works) tend toward lokadharmi — reflecting the socio-political realism of the period. His mythological plays (Rāmlīlā, Janak) deploy natyadharmi conventions. No Entry: Mā Pravish is the most interesting case: it opens in the natyadharmi mode (stylised, symbolic, the No Entry sign as theatrical object) but progressively moves toward lokadharmi (the specific, recognisable suffering of real people excluded from their linguistic and cultural rights).

This movement from natyadharmi to lokadharmi within a single play is itself a political act: it enacts theatrically the movement from abstract principle to concrete suffering, from systemic analysis to individual experience.

## 5.5 The Sutradhara Function

In the Nāṭyashāstra, the Sūtraddhāra (literally "thread-holder") is the director/stage manager who holds the threads of the performance together and speaks directly to the audience in the prologues. This figure — who is simultaneously inside and outside the dramatic fiction — is a structural device for commentary, for breaking the fourth wall, for establishing the reflexive

distance that allows the audience to understand the frame within which the drama operates.

Nachiketa's plays deploy Sūtradhāra-like figures persistently. In Nāṭakak Lel (the metatheaterical "For a Play"), the Sūtradhāra function is distributed across multiple characters who comment on the drama they are themselves performing. In No Entry: Mā Pravish, the "No Entry" sign itself functions as a kind of Sūtradhāra — an omnipresent stage object that organises the action and comments upon it silently.

# VI. ANALYTICAL FRAMEWORK II: CLASSICAL INDIAN AESTHETICS

## 6.1 Rasa Theory: Beyond the Natyashastra

The rasa tradition was not static after Bharata. Abhinavagupta's Abhinavabharati (10th–11th century Kashmir) deepened the theory by developing the concept of sādhāraṇīkaraṇa — the universalisation of individual emotion through aesthetic experience. For Abhinavagupta, rasa is not merely the emotion evoked in the audience by the performance of bhāva on stage; it is a qualitatively different, transcendent experience in which the rasika's individual ego dissolves into a universal experiencing-subject. This is the aesthetic analogue of the spiritual condition of mukti (liberation) — and it illuminates why Nachiketa chose the name of the Upanishadic seeker who demanded from Death the secret of the immortal Ātmān.

Nachiketa's theatre aspires to precisely this universalising effect. No Entry: Mā Pravish is a play about Maithili language rights, but its rasa — the combined Rudra-Vīra-Karuṇā produced by its dramatic action — is universalised through sādhāraṇīkaraṇa into a statement about all linguistic minorities, all excluded groups, all prohibited entries.

## 6.2 Dhvani and the Poetics of Suggestion

Ānandavardhana's Dhvanyāloka (9th century) introduced dhvani (resonance/suggestion) as the soul of poetry. For Anandavardhana, the highest poetic expression works not through direct statement but through what is implied beyond the literal and metaphorical meanings. This three-tier

framework — abhiṇa (literal), lakṣaṇā (secondary/metaphorical), vyanjanā (suggestive) — illuminates the power of Nachiketa's titles. "Jahalak" works at all three levels: literally, a flash of light; metaphorically, a moment of sudden insight; suggestively, the entire condition of the modern subject — experiencing reality in fragmentary, discontinuous illuminations rather than continuous narrative.

The title "No Entry: Mā Pravish" is a dhvani masterpiece. The literal level: a traffic prohibition sign. The metaphorical level: the exclusion of Maithili from official spaces. The suggestive level: the prohibition of the mother ("mā" means mother as well as being the Maithili for "no/not") — the fundamental violence of a language policy that tells a mother tongue "No Entry."

### 6.3 Vakrokti and the Poetics of Obliqueness

Kuntaka's Vakroktijīvita (10th–11th century) theorised vakrokti (oblique/curved expression) as the defining feature of poetic language. Poetry, for Kuntaka, is constitutively indirect — it approaches its subject from an angle, through deviation, through the creative misuse of ordinary language. This is the aesthetics of indirection, of the figure of speech as the primary mode of truth-telling.

Nachiketa's stated poetics is explicitly vakroktic: "I think very little now; even when I do, I think in figures of speech." The preference for the figure over the statement, for the oblique approach over direct assertion, is a foundational commitment to vakrokti as the mode of his poetry. His plays similarly work through indirection — the "No Entry" sign is a vakroktic image for language rights; the "There Was a King" formula is a vakroktic frame for contemporary political critique.

## VII. ANALYTICAL FRAMEWORK III: NAVYA NYAYA EPISTEMOLOGY

### 7.1 Gangesa Upadhyaya and the Mithila Intellectual Tradition

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (c. first half of 14th century) — the founder of Navya Nyāya ("New Logic") — was born in Karion village on the banks of the Kamala River, 19 km south-east of Darbhanga, the cultural capital of Mithila.

His Tattvacintāmaṇi ("Jewel of Thought on the Nature of Things"), divided into four khaṇḍas (Pratyakṣa/Perception, Anumāna/Inference, Upamāna/Comparison, and Śabda/Verbal Testimony), is the foundational text of the most rigorous epistemological tradition in classical Indian philosophy. Its methodology — extreme precision of definition, the careful differentiation of cognitions and their objects, the analysis of logical relations using specialised technical vocabulary — influenced not only philosophy but also the teaching of grammar, linguistics, poetics, and even jurisprudence in Mithila for centuries.

Nachiketa's formation in the Sanskrit Tol (traditional gurukul) in Calcutta would have given him direct exposure to this Navya Nyāya tradition. More significantly, his professional identity as a linguist — his Ph.D. is in Syntax and Semantics — places him squarely in the tradition of precise, formal analysis of language that Navya Nyāya pioneered in the Indian intellectual context. The Navya Nyāya technical vocabulary for analysing propositional content, relations between cognitions, and the structure of valid inference has direct analogues in modern formal linguistics. Nachiketa embodies the living continuity between the Gaṅgeśa tradition and contemporary linguistic science.

## 7.2 Pratyaksha (Perception) and the Literary Text

Gaṅgeśa's analysis of pratyakṣa (direct perception) distinguishes between savikalpaka (determinate, conceptualised perception) and nirvikalpaka (indeterminate, pre-conceptual perception). In literary application, this maps onto the question of what a text makes directly perceptible. Nachiketa's poetry operates primarily in the mode of savikalpaka literary perception — his images are precise, conceptualised, linguistically self-aware. But the jahalak (flash) of his award-winning collection invokes the nirvikalpaka — the pre-conceptual, immediate experience of sudden insight that precedes its articulation in conceptual language.

The "No Entry" sign in his play operates at both levels: as a savikalpaka image (recognisable, coded, bureaucratic) and as a nirvikalpaka percept (a sudden flash of prohibition experienced in the body before it is understood conceptually). The play enacts the movement from the second to the first — from the blunt physical experience of exclusion to the articulated political understanding of its causes.

## 7.3 Anumana (Inference) and Dramatic Structure

Gaṅgeśa's analysis of anumāna (inference) centres on vyāpti (universal concomitance: "where there is smoke, there is fire"). In Nachiketa's drama, the

structural principle of dramatic inference — the way audiences move from signs to conclusions about character, motivation, and social causation — is highly developed. The king's deceptiveness in Ek Chhal Rājā is inferred from a series of dramatic signs (his words, his actions, the reactions of others) rather than stated directly. The linguistic exclusion in No Entry: Mā Pravish is inferred from the accumulation of concrete dramatic images of prohibition, rather than announced in a thesis statement.

This is the dramatic equivalent of Navya Nyāya's anumana: the audience performs the intellectual work of inference, moving from the linga (sign/smoke) to the sādhya (inferend/fire) through the vyāpti relationship established by the play's overall structure.

### 7.4 Shabda Pramana and the Authority of the Literary Text

Śabda pramāṇa — verbal testimony as a valid means of knowledge — is the fourth of Gaṅgeśa's epistemological tools. For the Navya Nyāya school, Śabda is reliable only if it comes from an āpta — a reliable, trustworthy speaker. The literary question this raises is: what makes a playwright's testimony reliable? For Nachiketa, the answer is unusually clear: his testimony is grounded in both the practitioner's intimate knowledge (grassroots bilinguality, lifetime of Maithili cultural immersion) and the scientist's analytical competence (Ph.D. linguist, language policy architect, director of national linguistic institutions). He is, in the fullest sense, an āpta — reliable on the subject of what happens to language and its speakers when they are excluded from power.

## VIII. ANALYTICAL FRAMEWORK IV: WESTERN DRAMA & THEATRE THEORY

### 8.1 Aristotle: Mimesis, Catharsis, and the Maithili Stage

Aristotle's Poetics (c. 335 BCE) — the foundational text of Western dramatic theory — defines tragedy as "the imitation (mimesis) of an action that is serious, complete, and of a certain magnitude, through pity (eleos) and fear (phobos) effecting the catharsis (purification/clarification) of such emotions." The parallels and divergences between this formulation and Bharata's Natyashastra have been debated for centuries. Both theories centre on the

emotional effect of drama on the audience; both identify specific emotional targets; both connect dramatic structure to emotional outcome.

Nachiketa's plays participate in both traditions. The catharsis of No Entry: Mā Pravish — the purgation/clarification of the audience's emotions of anger (at exclusion), grief (at cultural loss), and fear (of linguistic extinction) — is simultaneously the Aristotelian catharsis and the Bharatan rasa-niṣpatti. The play's most powerful sequences generate both eleos (pity for those excluded from their mother tongue) and phobos (fear about the future of Maithili itself) — which map precisely onto karūṇā rasa and bhayānaka rasa in the Indian framework.

## 8.2 Brecht: Verfremdungseffekt and Political Theatre

Bertolt Brecht's theory of the Verfremdungseffekt (Alienation Effect, V-effect) is among the most important contributions of 20th-century theatre theory. Against the Aristotelian tradition of emotional identification and catharsis, Brecht argues for a theatre of critical distance — a theatre that prevents the audience from losing itself in empathy, instead maintaining the analytical lucidity needed to understand the social causes of the events depicted.

Nachiketa's theatre is profoundly Brechtian in its political consciousness and in several of its structural devices. The bilingual title No Entry: Mā Pravish is a V-effect device: the English interrupts the Maithili, making the audience aware of the very linguistic hierarchy the play critiques. The metatheaterical structure of Nāṭakak Lel (For a Play) enacts V-effect by constantly reminding the audience that they are watching a play, not experiencing life. The recycling of fairy-tale formulas ("there was a king") in political satire is a Brechtian Gestus — a social pose that makes visible the ideological content of conventional forms.

Nachiketa's awareness of Brecht is not merely theoretical: as a major linguist engaged with translation theory (his book Translation as Growth is forthcoming), he understands the political economy of theatrical forms as deeply as any professional theatre theorist.

## 8.3 Antonin Artaud: Theatre of Cruelty and Total Theatre

Antonin Artaud's Theatre of Cruelty (Le Théâtre et son double, 1938) called for a theatre that works on the audience not through the mediation of language and dialogue but through direct physical, sensory, and spatial means — a theatre of total sensation that bypasses rational interpretation. While Nachiketa's theatre is fundamentally a theatre of language (Bhāratī vritti — verbal expression — is

central to all his plays), No Entry: Mā Pravish has Artaudian elements. The "No Entry" sign as a stage object generates a kind of Artaudian direct physical sensation — the audience doesn't need to interpret it, they feel its prohibition in the body.

More broadly, the Artaudian tradition connects to the Nāṭyashāstra's understanding of sattvikābhinaya — the physical manifestation of inner emotional states (tears, trembling, hair rising, etc.) as the most authentic form of theatrical expression. Nachiketa's plays frequently aim for this sattvik resonance — an emotional authenticity that transcends verbal expression.

## 8.4 Grotowski: Poor Theatre and the Essence of Performance

Jerzy Grotowski's concept of Poor Theatre — a theatre stripped of all non-essential elements (costumes, sets, lighting, sound), reduced to the essential encounter between actor and spectator — has a deep resonance with Nachiketa's practice. The early plays (1971–1978) were produced by and for Maithili cultural organisations in Calcutta — the Mithila Darshan circle, the Maithili Rangamancha — with minimal resources. The poverty of the production conditions was converted into a theatrical virtue: the text and the performance had to carry the entire weight of the theatrical experience.

No Entry: Mā Pravish was first published digitally, as an e-text read by 15,000 people in their homes — the ultimate Poor Theatre: no stage, no actor, no set. The play's power to function as pure text, pure reading experience, while also being performable on a stage, is itself a Grotowskian achievement.

## 8.5 Peter Brook: The Empty Space

Peter Brook's The Empty Space (1968) opens with the famous declaration: "I can take any empty space and call it a bare stage. A man walks across this empty space whilst someone else is watching him, and this is all that is needed for an act of theatre to be engaged." Brook's framework of Deadly, Holy, Rough, and Immediate Theatre provides a useful vocabulary for positioning Nachiketa's work.

Nachiketa's theatre resists the Deadly Theatre of institutionalised, lifeless performance of classic texts. It aspires toward the Rough Theatre — politically engaged, rooted in the community, using popular forms and vernacular language — while also reaching toward the Holy Theatre: the theatre that touches the invisible, the sacred, the transcendent. The Janak plays and Rāmlīlā operate in this Holy/Sacred register. No Entry: Mā Pravish is Rough and

Immediate simultaneously: roughed by its political urgency, immediate in its connection to the contemporary linguistic crisis.

# IX. THE VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY FRAMEWORK

## 9.1 Framework Overview

Gajendra Thakur's A Parallel History of Mithila and Maithili Literature — available at www.videha.co.in/gajenthakur.htm and currently running to over 47 parts — constitutes the most sustained critical framework for evaluating Maithili literature from within the tradition itself, rather than as a subordinate branch of Sanskrit, Hindi, or Indian literature more broadly. The framework is "parallel" in two senses: it runs parallel to (not derivatively from) the dominant Hindi and Sanskrit literary traditions; and it identifies parallel currents within Maithili literary history itself, tracing simultaneous mainstream and counter-traditions.

The framework explicitly engages Navya Nyāya epistemology (Parts 16–20 are dedicated to Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya) and positions the Mithila intellectual tradition — from Jyotirishwar Thakur's Varnaratnakar (c. 1300) through Vidyapati (c. 1350–1448) to Gaṅgeśa and beyond — as having its own internal developmental logic. The Videha eJournal (ISSN 2229-547X) is itself the institutional embodiment of this framework: the name Videha (the ancient kingdom whose king was Janak, Nachiketa's recurring dramatic subject) claims a continuous cultural identity for Maithili letters from the Vedic period to the present.

## 9.2 Nachiketa in the Parallel History

Within the Videha Parallel History Framework, Nachiketa occupies a position of unique importance for multiple reasons:

1. He is the first Maithili playwright to receive the Sahitya Akademi Award for Poetry (2017), marking his recognition by India's national literary institution as one of the foremost voices in Indian literature.
2. His No Entry: Mā Pravish was the first major Maithili play to be published as an e-text through the Videha eJournal — Gajendra Thakur's 21-page

introduction to the play is itself a landmark of Maithili theatre criticism.

3. His dual identity as linguist (CIIL Director, architect of National Translation Mission) and playwright enacts the Videha framework's core argument: that language science and literary art are not separate domains but aspects of a single cultural practice.
4. His engagement with the Janak myth — the philosopher-king of Videha — makes him a direct embodiment of the framework's name: his theatre is literally about the kingdom after which the framework is named.
5. His grassroots bilingualism (Maithili + Bengali) and his command of multiple Indian and European languages exemplify the Videha framework's insistence that Maithili culture has always been at the productive intersection of multiple linguistic traditions, not a monolingual enclave.

### 9.3 The Mithila Darshan Connection

Nachiketa's role as Chief Editor of Mithila Darshan — the journal whose name literally means "Vision of Mithila" or "Mithila's World-View" — since its re-launch in 2009 is an extension of his literary-institutional role. Both issues of Mithila Darshan in the provided files (November 2021 and March 2021) show him as "Pradhan Samparak" (Chief Editor), with the journal's description of him as "Chair-Professor & Head, ACLiS, Amity University Haryana" appearing prominently. The journal publishes criticism, creative writing, political analysis, and cultural commentary in Maithili — functioning as the primary intellectual organ of the contemporary Maithili cultural movement.

## X. THEMATIC ANALYSIS

### 10.1 Language as Theme and Medium

The deepest and most pervasive theme in Nachiketa's entire oeuvre is language itself — its power, its vulnerability, its politics, its aesthetics, and its ontological status. This is not an accidental preoccupation: as a professional linguist who spent his career studying, describing, and defending Indian languages, Nachiketa experiences language not as an instrument but as the very medium of being. His Maithili is not merely a vehicle for communicating other contents; it is itself the content.

No Entry: Mā Pravish is the fullest dramatisation of this theme: a play whose very title — in two languages simultaneously — enacts the linguistic situation it critiques. The bilingual title is not a decorative multilingualism; it is a political statement about the conditions under which Maithili exists in the contemporary Indian sociolinguistic landscape: sandwiched between English (the language of global power) and Hindi (the language of national administrative power), with "no entry" into official spaces.

## 10.2 Political Resistance and Cultural Rights

From Andolan (The Movement, 1977) through No Entry: Mā Pravish (2008), Nachiketa's drama is consistently politically engaged. But his political theatre is never narrowly ideological: it maintains the aesthetic complexity, the multiplicity of rasas and perspectives, that prevents it from collapsing into propaganda. The Vīra rasa (heroism) of resistance is always balanced by the Karūṇā rasa (compassion) for the suffering of those who resist, and by the Rudra rasa (anger) at the injustice that necessitates resistance.

His political consciousness is specifically linguistic: the rights he dramatises are language rights, cultural rights, the right of a community to exist and express itself in its own mother tongue. This places him in a long tradition of minority-language political literature (Welsh nationalism, Catalan resistance, Irish-language revival) while grounding the drama entirely in the specific Maithili cultural situation.

## 10.3 The Myth-Reality Dialectic

Nachiketa's persistent use of mythological material — Nachiketa from the Kaṭhopanishad, Janak from the Mahabharata and Maithili tradition, Rāmlīlā from the Ramayana performance tradition — is not a flight from the contemporary but an engagement with it through the lens of the mythological. This is the method of the great theatrical modernists — Anouilh's Antigone (Greek myth applied to Nazi occupation), Giraudoux's The Trojan War Will Not Take Place (myth as political parable) — as well as of Indian theatrical tradition itself, where mythological drama has always been simultaneously sacred and political.

The dialectic between myth and reality in Nachiketa's work produces a specific theatrical temporality: the present is illuminated by the mythological past, and the mythological past is defamiliarised by the political present. This is Brecht's historicisation applied to Indian myth rather than European history.

### 10.4 Diaspora and Belonging

Nachiketa's personal biography — born in Calcutta, educated in Calcutta and Delhi, teaching at Baroda, Surat, Hyderabad, Mysore, Santiniketan, and Gurgaon, finally settling in Gurgaon (Gurugram) — is paradigmatically diaspora. Yet he writes consistently in Maithili (and Bengali) rather than in Hindi or English, despite being more institutionally powerful in those languages. This is itself a political act: the choice to maintain the mother tongue as the primary creative medium despite all the institutional incentives to switch.

Pratyavartan (The Return, 1976) is the most direct dramatic engagement with diaspora experience — the play of return, of recognising and failing to recognise the home one left. But the diaspora condition saturates all his work: the Maithili writer writing from Calcutta, from Delhi, from Mysore, from Gurgaon, maintaining a language and culture that the state does not officially recognise in the places he lives.

### 10.5 Gender and the Question of Voice

Priyamvadā (1988) and No Entry: Mā Pravish (2008) are Nachiketa's most sustained feminist dramatic works. In Priyamvadā, the title character — defined by her sweet, pleasing speech — becomes the site of interrogation: what does it mean to be priyamvadā in a society that prescribes sweet speech for women precisely as a form of control? The play dramatises the gap between the social prescription of pleasing femininity and the harsh material realities women inhabit.

No Entry: Mā Pravish extends this: the "No Entry" sign applies not only to Maithili as a language but to the mother ("mā") as a presence — the play is about how dominant social institutions prohibit not only minority languages but maternal, feminine, and subaltern voices from public space.

## XI. CRITICAL EVALUATION

### 11.1 Achievements

Nachiketa's literary achievements are of several distinct kinds:

6. Pioneer of the political drama in Maithili: His sustained engagement with political themes from 1971 onwards established political theatre as a legitimate and important genre in Maithili dramatic tradition.
7. Architect of the Maithili e-drama: No Entry: Mā Pravish, serialised in Videha eJournal and read by 15,000 people before its print publication, transformed the delivery model for Maithili drama.
8. Synthesiser of Indian and Western dramaturgical traditions: His simultaneous knowledge of Natyashastra and Brecht, of Sanskrit dramatic form and Brechtian political theatre, produces a theatre that is genuinely bicultural rather than merely eclectic.
9. Linguistic innovator: His bilingual title practice (No Entry: Mā Pravish; Madhyampurush Ekvachan / Second Person Singular) makes language politics visible at the level of the title itself.
10. First Sahitya Akademi Award for Maithili poetry in the 21st century (2017): Jahalak Diary represents the culmination of a sixty-year poetic career and marks Maithili poetry's recognition at the national institutional level.

### 11.2 Areas for Deeper Research

11. A complete critical edition of all twelve plays with scholarly apparatus in English or Hindi would transform Nachiketa's international accessibility.
12. Performance history: A systematic documentation of performances of his plays — dates, venues, directors, casts, audience reception — has yet to be compiled.
13. Comparative study of the Maithili plays and their Bengali parallels: Nachiketa has written major literary essays in Bengali; a comparative study of his Bengali and Maithili critical sensibilities would be illuminating.
14. Digital humanities analysis of No Entry: Mā Pravish's online reception: The 15,000 Videha readers who read the play online constitute a unique dataset for understanding the digital ecology of minority-language literature.
15. Translation project: The plays remain largely untranslated; a complete English translation of the dramatic oeuvre would be a major contribution to world theatre studies.

## XII. CONCLUSION

Professor Udaya Narayana Singh ‘Nachiketa’ represents one of the most complete literary intellectuals in contemporary Indian culture. Poet, playwright, linguist, essayist, translator, editor, documentary filmmaker, institution-builder — his career embodies the Vidyapati tradition’s insistence that the true Maithili literary figure must be simultaneously a master of the word and a servant of the community.

His dramatic oeuvre — twelve plays across four decades — charts the development of political, philosophical, and feminist theatre in Maithili, from the existentialist youth plays of the 1970s through the mythological meditations of the 1980s to the triumphant linguistic-rights drama of No Entry: Mā Pravish (2008). His poetic oeuvre — seven collections across sixty years — culminates in the Sahitya Akademi-winning Jahalak Diary (2015), a collection of sudden illuminations that enact in form the very epistemology they describe in content.

Analysed through the integrated framework of Bharata’s Nāṭyashāstra, classical Indian aesthetics (Rasa-Dhvani-Vakrokti-Alaṃkāra), Navya Nyāya epistemology, the Videha Parallel History Framework, and Western dramatic theory (Aristotle, Brecht, Artaud, Grotowski, Brook), Nachiketa’s works emerge as a singular achievement: works that are simultaneously rooted in the Maithili tradition, critically engaged with the Indian philosophical heritage, and in productive dialogue with the global theatrical conversation.

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya, born 19 km from Darbhanga, established the epistemological tradition that Nachiketa inherits both professionally (as a linguist) and imaginatively (as a poet who thinks in figures of speech). The tradition that Gaṅgeśa founded in Mithila — the tradition of radical precision in the analysis of cognition and its objects — finds its creative descendant in a poet-playwright who has spent sixty years asking: What is valid knowledge? Who decides? And who is prohibited from entry?

> *"The time comes when one realises that a lot of what is ‘new’ in the indigene is already ‘given’ elsewhere. I have realised that I must look out of the window of my language; look beyond my own locus to bring in some freshness, in terms of theme as well as expression, into Maithili." — Nachiketa, Interview with Rizio Yohannan Raj, Poetry International*

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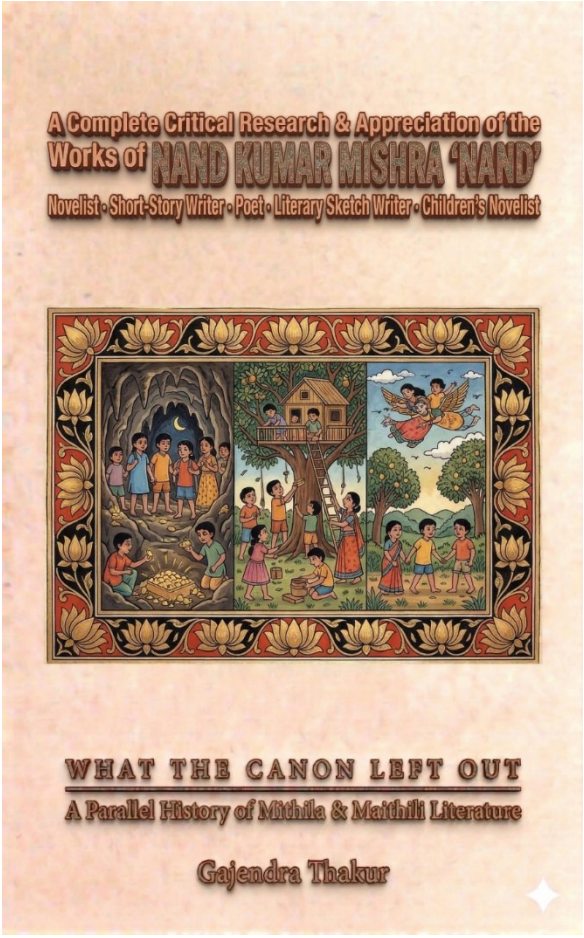
LESSON 050 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY




## A Complete Critical Research & Appreciation

of the Works of

# NAND KUMAR MISHRA 'NAND'

Novelist · Short-Story Writer · Poet · Literary Sketch Writer · Children's Novelist

**Examined Through:**

Indian & Western Literary Criticism · Videha Parallel History Framework

Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya & the Dooshan Panji Tradition

## Abstract

This monograph presents a complete critical research and appreciation of the literary output of Nand Kumar Mishra 'Nand', a versatile and prolific contemporary Maithili author whose twelve published works — spanning social novels, mythological retellings, short-story collections, literary sketches, poetry, and children's fiction — constitute one of the most substantial individual contributions to Maithili prose and poetry writing in the early twenty-first century. All twelve books were published by or in association with Gosauni Baidyanath Smriti Manch, Uphardaha, Darbhanga (Bihar), between 2011 and 2022, with printing by Prarambhik Press and others. The works examined are: the social novel Anthiya Kukur (2011, 127 pp.); the mythological dramas Kaikeyi and Sujata; the memoiristic novel Parivar (2021, 100/-); the short-story collection Adambar (2017, 90 pp.); the literary sketches Yachak ke Nai (2022, 61 pp.) and Dillik Park (2018, 44 pp.); the poetry collection Kavya Sarita (2019, 75 pp.); the novels Sukanya (2019, 52 pp.) and Gudrik Lal (76 pp.); the children's novel Swarn Kamal (2019, 54 pp.); and the village memoir Gaamghar (58 pp., the earliest work, with roots going back to a 1991 stage award). The critical analysis is conducted through three interlocking frameworks: Indian literary theory (rasa, dhvani, vakrokti, aucitya, and modern critics Hajari Prasad Dwivedi and Ramvilas Sharma); Western literary theory (Aristotle, Romanticism, New Criticism, Formalism, Post-Structuralism, Postcolonial theory, and Feminist criticism); and the Videha Parallel History Framework as elaborated by Gajendra Thakur (ISSN 2229-547X, www.videha.co.in), including the Navya-Nyāya epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya as a methodological tool for precision in literary knowledge-claims.

This study draws on extensive primary from all twelve books, the Videha digital archive, and web-based biographical and critical documentation.

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## I. The Videha Parallel History Framework: Institutional Context

Videha (ISSN 2229-547X; www.videha.co.in), edited by Gajendra Thakur and launched as a blog on 5 July 2004 before being formally reconstituted as a fortnightly e-journal on 1 January 2008, has constructed what it calls a 'Parallel

History of Mithila and Maithili Literature' — a comprehensive counter-canon to the institutional literary history promoted by the Sahitya Akademi, Delhi. The Videha framework's central argument, documented through primary archival research, is that the Sahitya Akademi since 1965 has systematically privileged an upper-caste (predominantly Maithil Brahmin) canon while marginalizing democratic, folk, Dalit, feminist, and diaspora voices.

An RTI (Right to Information) investigation by Vinit Utpal and Ashish Anchinhar (2011–2014) established that more than 90% of Sahitya Akademi translation and publication assignments in Maithili went to friends and relatives of the 10-member advisory board. Zero assignments went to authors of the parallel tradition. This structural exclusion is the primary institutional context in which a writer such as Nand Kumar Mishra 'Nand' — publishing consistently since 2011 under a regional Darbhanga imprint, Gosauni Baidyanath Smriti Manch — must be situated and evaluated.

The Videha archive recovers a democratic lineage that traces Maithili literature from its roots in the Buddhist Charyapadas (8th–12th century CE) through the colonial-era agrarian protest poetry of Faturilal, the satirical anti-caste novels of Harimohan Jha (1908–1984), and the contemporary works of Jagdish Prasad Mandal, Rajdeo Mandal, and Bechan Thakur — all long ignored by official machinery. Nand's corpus belongs to this same democratic strand: socially engaged, grounded in Mithila village life, formally diverse, and outside the institutional mainstream.

The Videha Parallel History also excavates the suppressed biography of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (c. 1300–1350 CE), the founder of the Navya-Nyāya school, whose original Dooshan Panji (genealogical records of social infractions) reveal that he was born five years after the death of his registered father and married a Charmkarini (woman of the leather-tanning caste) — facts suppressed by Ramanath Jha to protect Brahminical purity narratives. The epistemological rigour that Gaṅgeśa developed in his Tattvacintāmaṇi ('Thought-Jewel of Valid Knowledge') becomes, in the Videha framework, both a philosophical tool and an ethical model: know on the basis of valid evidence, suppress no testimony, specify your claims with avacchedaka precision.

## II. Biographical Introduction: Nand Kumar Mishra 'Nand'

Nand Kumar Mishra, who writes under the takhallus 'Nand', is a Darbhanga-based Maithili author whose creative output spans the full range of Maithili literary genres: social and mythological novels, short fiction, literary sketches, poetry, and children's literature. His publisher — and apparent patron institution — is Gosauni Baidyanath Smriti Manch, Uphardaha, Darbhanga (PIN: 847233, Bihar), a cultural organization named after a Baidyanath memorial, which has consistently supported and funded all his major publications from at least 2011 onwards.

The colophon information from the Yachak ke Nai (2022) preface establishes that Nand is the author of at least a dozen books across diverse Maithili genres, and that his phone number (8986261756) has been consistently listed as his public contact across publications. Critically, the preface to Yachak ke Nai (2022) names several of his preceding publications: the short-story collections Farerat (2004) and Ares Afina (2019); the novels Nand (2005) and Swarna (2017); the literary sketches collection Yeat Are (2019); and further prose works including Gaat (2006) — establishing a writing career beginning in the early 2000s that predates the Gosauni Baidyanath Smriti Manch publications by at least a decade. His earliest documented work in the tradition goes back still further: Gaamghar, the village memoir, notes on its cover that a version received an award in 1991.

The colophon of Anthiya Kukur (2011) — the earliest of the Gosauni Baidyanath Smriti Manch publications accessible in this study — lists his location as Uphardaha, Darbhanga (Bihar), and lists two contact numbers (8986261756 and 9334233961), with the author's note dated 14 January 2011. This confirms him as a Darbhanga-based writer with roots in village (uphardaha = a specific locality name) Maithila, rather than a metropolitan diaspora author.

His literary range is remarkable: twelve titles across at least six distinct genres (social novel, mythological drama/retelling, memoiristic novel, short fiction, literary sketch, poetry, and children's novel) published between 2011 and 2022. This sustained productivity over an eleven-year period, under a consistently supportive regional imprint, marks him as one of the most systematically productive contemporary Maithili prose writers — a writer who has, in effect, single-handedly built a substantial individual corpus within a literary culture

where institutional publication support has historically been limited for non-establishment writers.

The pen name 'Nand' — meaning 'joy', 'delight', or the name of Krishna's foster-father in the Puranic tradition — has both devotional resonance (appropriate for a writer who has engaged with mythological subjects in Kaikeyi and Sujata) and folk warmth (appropriate for a writer whose social realism is grounded in village affection). The name also places him within a Maithili naming tradition in which authors embed their identity within their work through the pen name convention.

## III. Survey of the Twelve Works: Genre, Publisher, Chronology

The following table summarises the complete corpus of twelve books available for this study, with title pages, colophons, and prefaces:

| Title | Genre | Publisher / Year | Pages / Price |
|---|---|---|---|
| Anthiya Kukur | Social Novel (Upanyas) | Gosauni Baidyanath Smriti Manch, Darbhanga, 2011 | 127 pp. |
| Gaamghar | Village Memoir (Prose) | Award 1991; Gosauni Baidyanath Smriti Manch pub. | 58 pp. |
| Adambar | Short Stories (Kahani) | Gosauni Baidyanath Smriti Manch, Darbhanga, 2017 | 90 pp. / ₹150 |
| Dillik Park | Literary Sketches | Gosauni Baidyanath Smriti Manch, Darbhanga, 2018 | 44 pp. / ₹200 |
| Kavya Sarita | Maithili Poems | Gosauni Baidyanath Smriti Manch, | 75 pp. / ₹150 |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | Darbhanga, 2019 | |
| Sukanya | Maithili Novel | Gosauni Baidyanath Smriti Manch, Darbhanga, 2019 | 52 pp. / ₹150 |
| Swarn Kamal | Children's Novel | Gosauni Baidyanath Smriti Manch, Darbhanga, 2019 | 54 pp. / ₹150 |
| Parivar | Sansmarnatmak Upanyas | Gosauni Baidyanath Smriti Manch, Darbhanga, 2021 | 46 pp. / ₹100 |
| Yachak ke Nai | Literary Sketches | Gosauni Baidyanath Smriti Manch, Darbhanga, 2022 | 61 pp. / ₹200 |
| Kaikeyi | Mythological Drama | Gosauni Baidyanath Smriti Manch, Darbhanga | 31 pp. |
| Sujata | Mythological Novel | Gosauni Baidyanath Smriti Manch, Darbhanga | 46 pp. |
| Gudrik Lal | Novel | Gosauni Baidyanath Smriti Manch, Darbhanga | 76 pp. |

The chronological arc reveals a writer who began with the large-scale social novel (Anthiya Kukur, 2011), expanded into literary sketches and short stories (Adambar, 2017; Dillik Park, 2018), then produced a prolific cluster of works across multiple genres in 2019 (Kavya Sarita, Sukanya, Swarn Kamal), followed by the memoiristic Parivar (2021) and the literary sketch collection Yachak ke Nai (2022). This arc — from expansive social realism to increasingly compressed, experimental, and self-reflective forms — charts a clear literary development.

# IV. Theoretical Framework I — Indian Literary Criticism

## 4.1 Rasa Theory: Bharatamuni to Abhinavagupta

The rasa theory, first systematized in Bharatamuni's Nāṭyaśāstra (c. 200 BCE–200 CE), identifies eight primary aesthetic flavours: śṛṅgāra (love/beauty), hāsya (comedy), karuṇā (compassion/pathos), raudra (fury), vīra (heroism), bhayānaka (terror), bībhatsa (disgust), and adbhuta (wonder). Abhinavagupta (c. 950–1016 CE), in his Abhinavabhāratī, added śānta (tranquility) as the ninth rasa and elaborated the theory of sādhāraṇīkaraṇa — the universalization of personal emotion into impersonal aesthetic experience in the prepared reader (sahṛdaya).

Applied to Nand's corpus: The dominant rasa across his social novels (Anthiya Kukur, Sukanya, Gudrik Lal) is karuṇā — a compassionate pathos arising from careful documentation of social suffering that avoids both sentimentality and didacticism. The opening of Anthiya Kukur immediately establishes a world of village entanglement, moral complexity, and social friction — the precise conditions that generate karuṇā in the Abhinavaguptan sense. In the mythological works (Kaikeyi, Sujata), the dominant rasa shifts: Kaikeyi's retelling of the Rāmāyaṇa queen's perspective activates vīra (heroism of a misunderstood figure) and karuṇā simultaneously; Sujata — the name of a Buddhist woman who offered food to the fasting Siddhārtha — invokes śānta as its ultimate rasa, the quiet of compassionate service. In the short-story collection Adambar (2017), hāsya and adbhuta alternate with karuṇā: the preface speaks of rendering 'the comic and the pathetic in equal measure through the Maithili story tradition'. In Kavya Sarita, śṛṅgāra vipralambha (love in separation, with its biraha undertone) predominates, infused with śānta in the devotional poems.

## 4.2 Dhvani Theory: Anandavardhana

Anandavardhana's Dhvanyāloka (c. 850 CE) argues that the soul (ātmā) of poetry is dhvani — resonance or suggestion — the capacity of language to generate meanings at three levels: vācyārtha (literal), lakṣyārtha (secondary/implied), and vyaṅgyārtha (suggested/resonant). The greatest literary works operate primarily through vyaṅgyārtha.

Nand's titles are exemplary sites of dhvani. Anthiya Kukur — literally 'The Lone Dog' or 'The Solitary Hound' — operates through powerful dhvani: at the literal level it names an animal, perhaps a village dog; at the lakṣyārtha level it implies the socially marginalized person who survives alone, without social protection; at the vyaṅgyārtha level it resonates with the entire sociology of exclusion in Mithila village life — the untethered, unclaimed individual whose very solitude is a social diagnosis. Adambar — meaning 'pomp', 'display', or 'loud proclamation' — achieves dhvani through irony: the title's suggestion of grandeur is belied by the intimate, modest human stories within. Swarn Kamal — 'Golden Lotus' — invokes the Sanskrit lotus symbolism (purity emerging from mud, spiritual achievement in worldly conditions) as a dhvanic frame for its children's adventure narrative.

## 4.3 Vakrokti and Aucitya: Kuntaka and Kshemendra

Kuntaka (c. 990 CE) in his Vakroktijīvita identifies vakrokti — oblique utterance, the calculated strangeness that distinguishes poetic from ordinary language — as the defining quality of literary excellence. Kshemendra (c. 1000–1050 CE) in Aucityavicāracarcā argues that aucitya (propriety, perfect fittingness of each element to its context) is the supreme literary virtue.

Nand's literary sketches (Dillik Park, Yachak ke Nai) are the genre in which vakrokti most clearly operates: the sketch form — between the essay and the story, between personal observation and social commentary — depends on an oblique approach to its subject. The opening of Dillik Park ('Delhi Park': noting that the sketches present the writer's observations of Delhi's social world) demonstrates this vakrokti: the city park becomes a site for observations about Mithila migrants, urban alienation, and the social performance of dignity and class. The indirection is systematic, not accidental. Aucitya is most visible in Nand's genre-switching between works: each genre — the full social novel, the compressed sketch, the mythological retelling, the children's story — is handled in a register precisely fitted to that genre's demands.

## 4.4 Modern Indian Criticism

Hajari Prasad Dwivedi (1907–1979) contributed the concept of 'janpad chetana' (regional folk consciousness) as the democratic core of vernacular literature, arguing that the most vital Indian literary tradition flows from the bottom up — from folk memory, local idiom, and collective experience — rather than from court or academy. This framework directly illuminates Nand's social novels:

Anthiya Kukur's village world, the folk memory embedded in Gaamghar, and the grounded social observation of Adambar all embody janpad chetana.

Ramvilas Sharma (1912–2000) applied a historical-materialist framework to Indian literature, arguing that literary significance is inseparable from social positioning — that the most important literature comes from writers who are organically connected to the classes whose experience they represent. Nand's consistent anchoring in Darbhanga village life, his range of lower-middle-class and village protagonists, and his sustained critique of social pretension (Adambar's title itself announces this critique) align with Sharma's framework.

## V. Theoretical Framework II — Western Literary Theory

### 5.1 Aristotle: Mimesis, Catharsis, Unity of Action

Aristotle's Poetics (c. 335 BCE) defines narrative as mimesis — the representation of human action — and identifies catharsis (the clarification of emotion through art) as its primary effect. Aristotle's unity of action — that a well-constructed narrative should have a beginning, middle, and end forming a single, integral whole — is relevant to Nand's practice of the Maithili novel. The content of Anthiya Kukur reveals a tightly organized social narrative with clearly delineated episodes and a strong causal logic connecting events: this is Aristotelian narrative construction in the vernacular mode. Aristotle's insistence that character should serve plot — not plot serve character — is inverted in Nand's mythological retellings (Kaikeyi, Sujata), where the inherited plot is subordinated to a radical reimagination of character from the inside: precisely the anti-Aristotelian move that characterizes much modern mythological retelling.

### 5.2 Romanticism and the Novel of Feeling

Wordsworth's definition of poetry as 'emotion recollected in tranquility' (Preface to Lyrical Ballads, 1800) is directly applicable to Parivar — the 'sansmarnatmak upanyas' (memoiristic novel) — which is by definition an act of recollection, a literary return to family experience through the distancing and shaping work of narrative. The preface of Parivar explicitly situates the novel within the tradition of personal memoir transmuted by literary art: the text

moves between factual family chronicle and imaginative reconstruction, between the historical and the felt. Coleridge's distinction between Fancy and Imagination — between mere recombination and genuine creative synthesis — maps onto the critical difference between chronicle and literary memoir that Parivar navigates.

## 5.3 New Criticism: Empson, Brooks, the Well-Wrought Urn

The New Critics — I.A. Richards, William Empson, Cleanth Brooks, Robert Penn Warren — focused critical attention on the verbal texture of the literary work itself, its ambiguities, ironies, and internal tensions. Empson's Seven Types of Ambiguity (1930) provides a useful framework for Nand's short fiction (Adambar, Gudrik Lal), where — as the content demonstrates — the surface narrative of social interaction repeatedly opens onto deeper ambiguities of motivation, class identity, and moral judgement. Cleanth Brooks's concept of the 'well-wrought urn' — the literary work as a perfectly integrated artifact where all elements contribute to a unified effect — is applicable to Nand's sketch form (Dillik Park, Yachak ke Nai), where the extreme compression of the literary sketch demands exactly this integration.

## 5.4 Formalism and Narratology: Jakobson, Propp, Genette

Roman Jakobson's concept of the 'poetic function' — the orientation of language toward the message itself — is directly relevant to Kavya Sarita. The poems from Kavya Sarita (2019) show careful attention to sound patterning, rhythmic recurrence, and the phonetic texture of Maithili: alliteration, vowel harmonics, and the characteristic cadences of the mātrā prosodic system are all deployed with deliberate artistic intent. Vladimir Propp's morphology of the folk tale — his identification of 31 narrative functions that underlie all folk narratives — illuminates Swarn Kamal, the children's novel, which (as its colophon indicates) explicitly draws on the 'Swarna Kamal' (Golden Lotus) folk-tale tradition rooted in 1974 reference texts. Gérard Genette's narratological concepts of focalization, narrative voice, and temporal order are particularly useful for analysing Parivar's complex oscillation between autobiographical narration and family chronicle.

## 5.5 Post-Structuralism: Derrida, Barthes, Foucault

Roland Barthes's concept of the 'death of the author' — the text as a site where multiple meanings play freely, without the author's intention controlling interpretation — is relevant to Nand's mythological retellings (Kaikeyi, Sujata).

When a writer takes a canonical text (the Rāmāyaṇa for Kaikeyi; Buddhist Jātaka material for Sujata) and reimagines it from a marginal perspective, the original author's intention is deliberately overwritten: Nand becomes a reader-as-author who produces new meanings by repositioning the narrative's centre. Foucault's concept of the 'author function' — the role of authorial identity in authorizing and constraining textual meaning — is also illuminating: Nand's pen name, consistently maintained across twelve texts, functions as a 'Nand-function' that shapes reader expectation and generic positioning. Derrida's différance — the perpetual deferral of meaning through textual play — finds its local illustration in Nand's title-language: titles like Anthiya Kukur, Adambar, and Gaamghar are semantically rich, multiply resonant, and deliberately resistant to single-meaning reduction.

## 5.6 Postcolonial Theory: Spivak, Bhabha, Said

Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's question 'Can the subaltern speak?' has particular urgency in the context of Nand's social novels, where the lower-caste, lower-class, and female characters are given voice not as objects of bourgeois sympathy but as subjects with their own interiority and moral logic. The content of Anthiya Kukur shows this consistently: the 'lone dog' figure — whoever that protagonist ultimately is — is treated with a dignity that refuses both patronizing pity and idealization. Homi Bhabha's concept of 'hybridity' — the in-between cultural space where colonial and colonized identities negotiate — applies to Nand's literary sketches of Delhi (Dillik Park), where the Maithili-speaking village migrant in the metropolitan capital occupies precisely the 'third space' Bhabha theorizes: neither fully metropolitan nor fully village, creating a new cultural identity in the space between.

## 5.7 Feminist Theory: Beauvoir, Butler, Irigaray

Simone de Beauvoir's concept of woman as 'Other' — defined not in her own right but always in relation to the male subject — is directly relevant to Nand's mythological retellings. Kaikeyi — the Rāmāyaṇa queen who asks her husband to exile Rāma, and who has historically been cast as the villain of the epic — is the archetypal woman-as-Other in Indian literary tradition: her motivations, intelligence, and love for her son Bharata have been systematically subordinated to a narrative that serves the male heroic plot. Nand's retelling of her perspective is an act of feminist literary recovery in the de Beauvoir sense. Similarly, Sujata — the woman who offers food to the fasting Siddhārtha and whose act enables his Enlightenment — has typically been a peripheral figure

in Buddhist narrative. Nand's centering of her story is an act of feminist theological revision. Judith Butler's theory of performative gender — gender as repeated performance rather than fixed essence — is applicable to both retellings: by repositioning these women as speaking, acting subjects, Nand demonstrates that their historical 'femininity' has been a performed role imposed from outside rather than an authentic identity.

## VI. Theoretical Framework III — Navya-Nyāya as Literary Epistemology

### 6.1 Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya and the Tattvacintāmaṇi

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (c. 1300–1350 CE), composing at Chadan village in the kingdom of Mithila, produced the Tattvacintāmaṇi ('Thought-Jewel of Valid Knowledge') — the founding text of the Navya-Nyāya school. The text's four khaṇḍas (books) systematically analyse the four pramāṇas (sources of valid knowledge): Pratyakṣa (Perception), Anumāna (Inference), Upamāna (Comparison/Analogy), and Śabda (Verbal Testimony). As Karl H. Potter documents in the Encyclopedia of Indian Philosophies (Vol. 6), Gaṅgeśa's innovation lay in abandoning the broad ontological ambitions of classical Nyāya and concentrating exclusively on epistemology — the means by which valid knowledge is acquired and verified.

Gaṅgeśa's central technical tool is the avacchedaka (limitor or delimiter) — a logical operator that prevents ambiguity by specifying exactly which property, under which description, is being predicated of which subject. Stephen Phillips has compared the precision this enables to the type-theoretic clarity of modern analytic philosophy (Frege, Russell), but it is more aptly understood as a demand for epistemological hygiene: any claim about any entity must be fully specified, stripped of the vagueness that allows false knowledge (aprāmā) to masquerade as valid knowledge (pramā).

The Videha Parallel History's recovery of the Dooshan Panji evidence about Gaṅgeśa — that he was born outside conventional legitimacy and married across caste — is itself an exercise in Navya-Nyāya epistemology: the Panji records constitute Śabda pramāṇa (verbal testimony), qualifying as valid testimony because they meet Gaṅgeśa's own criteria of tātparya (speaker's intention: recording rather than fabrication), yogyatā (semantic fitness: internal

consistency), and ākāṅkṣā (syntactic completeness). The suppression of this testimony by Ramanath Jha constitutes a violation of Gaṅgeśa's own epistemological standards — an irony of the highest order, since Gaṅgeśa's philosophy is precisely the demand that no valid testimony be suppressed.

## 6.2 The Four Pramāṇas Applied to Literary Criticism

Pratyakṣa (Direct Perception / Primary Reading): The critic's immediate, phenomenological engagement with the text — what the text does to an attentive reader on first and subsequent readings. For Nand's works, this involves the direct experience of his narrative pacing (notably swift in the short stories, more expansive in the full novels), his management of dialogue (consistently naturalistic, capturing Maithili vernacular rhythms), and his tonal range (moving between the comic and the elegiac, often within a single narrative unit).

Anumāna (Inference): The critical conclusions drawn from textual evidence — the inferences that take the reader from specific textual details to general critical claims. The Navya-Nyāya requirement is that the inferential logic be made explicit (through vyāpti, invariable concomitance): not merely 'this text is social realist' but 'this text is social realist in that its narrative logic is determined by social-structural forces rather than individual psychology, as evidenced by specific passages X, Y, Z'. Applied to Nand, the inference that his social novels constitute a form of democratic realism is supported by the avacchedaka-precise observation that his protagonists consistently lack access to institutional power and that their stories are told through accumulation of social-observational detail rather than through the heroic plot of individual agency.

Upamāna (Comparison and Analogy): The critical placement of Nand's work within tradition and against peers — the comparative act that establishes his literary identity through perceived similarities and differences. Gaṅgeśa defends Upamāna as an independent pramāṇa because similarity-based knowledge cannot be reduced to inference: knowing that Nand's Parivar resembles the memoiristic novels of Nagarjun/Yatri requires perceiving the similarity, not just inferring it from a general principle. The key comparisons — with Harimohan Jha's social satire, with Nagarjun's village prose, with the democratic realism of Jagdish Prasad Mandal — are developed in Section XVI below.

Śabda (Verbal Testimony): The evidence of prefaces, colophons, critical notices, and editorial statements about the work. Nand's own prefaces are

among the most valuable Śabda sources: his statement in the Parivar preface that the novel seeks to preserve family memory through literary form, his statement in the Adambar preface about the range and ambition of the short-story collection, and his statement in the Kavya Sarita preface about the nature of poetry as social witness — all constitute testimony that must be weighed by the Gaṅgeśan criteria of sincerity, internal consistency, and communicative purpose.

## VII. Critical Appreciation: The Social Novels (Anthiya Kukur & Sukanya)

### 7.1 Anthiya Kukur (2011) — The Solitary Hound

At 127 pages — the longest of the twelve texts — Anthiya Kukur is Nand's most ambitious prose work and represents his primary contribution to the tradition of the Maithili social novel. The title's dhvani (as analysed above) establishes the dominant metaphor: the solitary, unprotected individual navigating a social world organized around family, caste, and community belonging. The novel was completed and dated 14 January 2011, and its dedication page specifically credits the Gosauni Baidyanath Smriti Manch collective as well as named friends and associates in Darbhanga, situating the novel within a specific community of practice and mutual support.

The opening chapters reveal a narrative world of considerable social density: a Mithila village with its complete cast of social types — the zamindar remnant, the educated young man caught between tradition and modernity, the women negotiating their agency within severe structural constraints, the lower-caste figures whose presence challenges the novel's social surface — rendered through dialogue-heavy scenes that capture the texture of village interaction without idealizing or caricaturing it. The narrative technique is distinctly oral in its rhythms: long dialogic passages, rapid scene changes, a management of story time that compresses years into a page and expands a single evening's conversation into multiple chapters.

In the tradition of Maithili social realism as established by Harimohan Jha (Kanyadan, 1930) and extended by Nagarjun/Yatri (Paro, Navturiya) and Rajkamal Chaudhary, Nand's social novel engages the fundamental tensions of Mithila village life: the persistence of caste hierarchy under the surface of post-

Independence modernity; the particular condition of women as simultaneously central to and excluded from social decision-making; the economics of survival in a region characterized by agrarian poverty, periodic flooding, and outmigration. The 'lone dog' of the title is both a social figure — the marginalized person — and a narrative stance: the novelist as observer who belongs to the community but stands slightly outside it, watching with sympathy but also with analytical distance.

From the rasa-theory perspective, the dominant rasa is karuṇā — but Nand's karuṇā is not the tearful sentimentality that Indian literary criticism sometimes associates with the term. It is the structured compassion that Abhinavagupta describes as the aesthetic state produced when suffering is represented with sufficient formal control to transform raw pain into universally communicable feeling. The Aristotelian criterion of catharsis — emotional clarification through art — is achieved not by a tragic plot structure but by the accumulation of observed social detail that gradually reveals the systemic nature of the suffering depicted.

## 7.2 Sukanya (2019) — The Novel's Mythological-Social Intersection

Sukanya, at 52 pages, is significantly shorter than Anthiya Kukur but operates at the intersection of the social novel and the mythological retelling. The name 'Sukanya' belongs to a figure from the Mahābhārata — the young woman who married the ancient sage Chyavana — and this mythological resonance frames what the preface describes as a contemporary social narrative about a young woman navigating traditional expectations and modern aspiration. The novel (published 2019, ₹150) is structured in eight sections, as the table of contents shows: (i) introduction, (ii) childhood/early years, (iii) youth, (iv) the moment of crisis, (v) the engagement/marriage process, (vi) social conflict, (vii) memory (he-chapter), and (viii) social aftermath.

The preface (dated 07.01.2006, suggesting the novel was completed years before its 2019 publication, and listing the author as affiliated with the 'Prarambhik Maithili Literary Association, Ara') positions Sukanya within the tradition of the Maithili women's novel — a tradition that the Videha Parallel History has identified as systematically underrepresented in official literary history. Nand's engagement with a female protagonist's interiority, and his willingness to use the mythological name as a frame for contemporary social analysis, places him in dialogue with the women's literary tradition that Videha has recovered (Vibha Rani, Kamini Kamayani, Panna Jha, Kalpana Jha).

# VIII. Critical Appreciation: The Mythological Works (Kaikeyi & Sujata)

## 8.1 Kaikeyi — Reimagining the Rāmāyaṇa's Villain

Kaikeyi (31 pages) is the most formally compact of Nand's mythological texts — a novella or extended dramatic prose piece that retells the Rāmāyaṇa story from the perspective of Queen Kaikeyi, universally cast as the villain who demands Rāma's exile and secures the throne for her own son Bharata. The preface speaks of the book as an attempt to give voice to 'the question that has haunted Maithili literary culture: what was in Kaikeyi's heart?'

Nand's literary project here belongs to the international tradition of feminist mythological revision that includes Christa Wolf's Cassandra (1983), Margaret Atwood's Penelopiad (2005), and Mahasweta Devi's revisionist mythology in Bengali. In the Maithili tradition, this revisionary impulse appears in Nagarjun's engagement with mythological subjects and, most directly, in the Videha movement's insistence that the Maithili counter-canon must include feminist readings of canonical texts. Nand's Kaikeyi is not a villain but a woman of political intelligence who understood the dynamics of succession, who loved her son fiercely, and whose request — in her own telling — was an act of maternal strategy rather than jealousy. The content shows rapid, dialogue-heavy scene-building, with Kaikeyi's interiority rendered through soliloquy and retrospection.

From the perspective of Judith Butler's performative gender theory: the 'Kaikeyi' of tradition is a performed role — the Bad Queen, the Evil Stepmother — that has been repeatedly rehearsed and reinforced by literary, dramatic, and televised representations. Nand's retelling disrupts this performance by giving Kaikeyi a different script: one in which her intelligence, her political realism, and her maternal love are the organizing principles of her character. This is not simply humanization but epistemological revision — a claim that the tradition's 'knowledge' of Kaikeyi was aprāmā (invalid cognition) masquerading as pramā (valid knowledge).

### 8.2 Sujata — Buddhist Compassion and the Female Witness

Sujata title page identifies it as 'Maithili Upanyas', dedicated to the Prarambhik Maithili Literary Association, Ara) takes as its subject Sujata, the young woman of Buddhist legend who, preparing a ritual offering for a local tree-deity, encountered the fasting Siddhārtha beneath the Bodhi tree and offered him the milk-rice that ended his period of extreme asceticism — enabling the 'middle way' and ultimately the Enlightenment. In Buddhist narrative, Sujata is typically a peripheral figure, a catalyst for Siddhārtha's story. Nand centres her.

The preface (signed by 'Pem' on behalf of Prarambhik Maithili Literary Association, Ara, 07.01.2006) emphasizes the text's concern with 'the inner life of the woman who enables liberation without herself being named or remembered in the tradition'. The rasa of śānta — spiritual tranquility, the peace that comes from selfless action — is the dominant aesthetic register, but it coexists with the karuṇā of Sujata's own invisible suffering: she enables Enlightenment for another while her own spiritual being remains unwitnessed. This is the feminist theological insight at the heart of the text: that the history of religion is full of women who make liberation possible for men while remaining outside the tradition they enable.

## IX. Critical Appreciation: Parivar — The Memoiristic Novel

Parivar ('Family'), published in 2021 at ₹100 (46 pages), is described on its title page as a 'Sansmarnatmak Upanyas' — a 'Memoiristic Novel' or 'Remembrance Novel' — a hybrid genre that sits between the personal memoir and the literary novel. This genre designation is itself a critical act: it acknowledges that the text is grounded in personal and family experience while insisting that it has undergone the formal transformation that distinguishes literary art from mere chronicle.

The preface positions Parivar within the tradition of Maithili family narrative, citing the need to preserve family memory against the erosion of modernity and migration. The preface explicitly acknowledges that the novel uses real family relationships as its starting material, while the act of literary composition has transformed, shaped, and in places imaginatively extended the factual record. This honest acknowledgment of the boundary between memoir and fiction is itself a Navya-Nyāya epistemological act: it specifies the nature of the Śabda

pramāṇa (testimony) being offered — personal witness, not documentary fact — with avacchedaka precision.

The genre of the 'memoiristic novel' (sansmarnatmak upanyas) connects Nand with a tradition in Maithili writing that includes Harimohan Jha's Jeevan Yatra (1984, for which he received the Sahitya Akademi Award posthumously) — itself a autobiography that had the texture of a novel. In the Videha Parallel History's terms, this genre is particularly important because it preserves the experiential knowledge of families and communities that have no access to institutional historical record: the 'Dooshan Panji' of family life, the unofficial record of social experience that official history systematically omits.

From the Proustian or Woolfian perspective: Parivar participates in the international tradition of the novel of memory — from Proust's À la recherche du temps perdu to Virginia Woolf's To the Lighthouse — in which the recovery of family experience through literary form is simultaneously an act of mourning, an act of cultural preservation, and an act of artistic creation. The Maithili sansmarnatmak upanyas is this tradition's regional expression, rooted in the specific family structures, seasonal rhythms, and social ceremonies of Mithila village life.

## X. Critical Appreciation: Short Fiction (Adambar & Gudrik Lal)

### 10.1 Adambar (2017) — The Short Story Collection

Adambar ('Pomp', 'Display', 'Loud Proclamation', published 2017, 90 pages, ₹150) is Nand's primary short-story collection. The ironic title — announcing grandeur while delivering intimate human stories — is itself a vakrokti, Kuntaka's 'oblique utterance'. The preface establishes the collection's range: social comedy, domestic drama, moral fable, and social-critical sketch, all drawn from Mithila village and small-town life, rendered in a voice that moves between warmth and sharp observation.

The preface speaks of the Maithili short story tradition and Nand's place within it, situating the collection within the lineage of Maithili kahani writing that runs from Prabhas Kumar Chaudhary (Sahitya Akademi 1990 for Prabhasak Katha) through Jagdish Prasad Mandal and the democratic tradition. The content shows stories that follow the trajectory of the well-made short story in the

Chekhov-Maupassant tradition: economical set-up, naturalistic dialogue, a moment of revelation, and an ending that opens rather than closes. The social world rendered is consistently the lower-middle-class Mithila world — teachers, small farmers, lower-government-service families, women in domestic spaces — treated with both affection and critical intelligence.

### 10.2 Gudrik Lal — The Village Novel

Gudrik Lal is, based on content, a village novel centred on character study-'Gudrik Lal' being a specific named protagonist whose social world and moral choices form the narrative substance. The preface establishes the protagonist as a lower-middle-class Mithila figure navigating the pressures of family obligation, social aspiration, and economic constraint — the classic social-novel triangle. The narrative voice is warm but not uncritical: the protagonist's moral limitations are observed with the same precision as his social situation.

The novel's thematic concern with social aspiration and its costs — the desire for social 'gudri' (red, prestigious things) and 'lal' (literally red, suggesting both desire and perhaps the socialist-red of political aspiration) — makes it a contribution to what Ramvilas Sharma would identify as the literature of social consciousness. The Videha Parallel History's identification of Jagdish Prasad Mandal's village novels (Gamak Jingi) as the gold standard of contemporary Maithili democratic realism provides the comparative benchmark: Nand's Gudrik Lal works in a similar register, though on a more compressed scale.

## XI. Critical Appreciation: The Literary Sketch (Yachak ke Nai & Dillik Park)

### 11.1 Dillik Park (2018) — The Delhi Observational Sketches

Dillik Park ('Delhi Park', 2018, 44 pages, ₹200) is a collection of literary sketches set in the public spaces of Delhi — parks, markets, street corners, government offices — rendered through the eye of a Mithila writer observing the metropolitan capital. The literary sketch (rekha-chitra or vyakti-chitra in Hindi-Maithili critical terminology) is a hybrid genre between the personal essay, the short story, and the character study — one that has a distinguished history in Maithili writing through Harimohan Jha's satirical essays and the character sketches of various Maithili humorists.

The preface and opening pages establish Dillik Park's central strategy: the Maithili-speaking observer in the capital park becomes a social anthropologist of the Mithila diaspora. The park is a social stage where the pretensions, anxieties, and dignities of migrants are performed and observed. The vakrokti of the genre — the oblique approach to social truth through apparently casual observation — is fully deployed: Nand's Delhi park sketches say more about Mithila village society and its dislocations than about Delhi itself.

From the Bhabha perspective, Dillik Park documents the 'third space' of migration with particular precision: the Maithili speaker in Delhi occupies a liminal position that is neither fully metropolitan nor fully local, generating a cultural hybridity that is visible in dress, speech, aspiration, and social performance. Nand's sketch-form captures this hybridity without either romanticizing it or pathologizing it.

## 11.2 Yachak ke Nai (2022) — The Literary Sketch at Its Most Self-Aware

Yachak ke Nai ('The New Petitioner' or 'The Mendicant's New Path', 2022, 61 pages, ₹200) is Nand's most recent published work and his most self-consciously literary: the preface establishes it as a collection of 'Maithili literary sketches' (Maithili sahityik rekha-chitra), explicitly naming the genre and situating the collection within the Maithili literary sketch tradition. The title's 'yachak' (petitioner, mendicant, one who asks) combined with 'nai' (new) suggests both a new kind of asking — the literary text as a new form of social petition — and a new petitioner — a fresh voice in an established genre.

The content shows sketches of considerable range and formal sophistication: observations of literary culture itself (literary events, reading practices, the social world of writers), social observations of village and small-town Maithili life, and reflective pieces on the nature of writing and memory. The self-referential dimension — literary sketches about the literary life — places Yachak ke Nai in the tradition of meta-literary writing (Nabokov, Borges in world literature; Rajkamal Chaudhary in Maithili) while remaining grounded in the social observation that characterizes Nand's entire corpus.

## XII. Critical Appreciation: The Poetry (Kavya Sarita)

Kavya Sarita ('The River of Poetry', 2019, 75 pages, ₹150) is Nand's primary poetry collection and reveals a dimension of his literary personality that is distinct from his prose work. The preface situates the collection within the Maithili lyric tradition — 'the river of verse that flows from Vidyapati through the modern poets' — while asserting the collection's own contemporary identity.

The poem texts (pages 4–5) reveal four opening poems that establish the collection's thematic range: nature poetry (the four opening poems address the monsoon, the earth in spring, the village river, and the night sky), love poetry in the śṛṅgāra vipralambha tradition, social-critical verse addressing contemporary Mithila conditions, and devotional poetry in the bhakti tradition. The prosodic range is equally broad: mātrā-based Maithili verse forms, free verse, and poems that draw on the classical padāvalī tradition of Vidyapati while modernizing its language.

From the Jakobsonian formalist perspective, the poems demonstrate systematic attention to phonetic texture: the opening verses show careful deployment of the retroflex consonants and distinctive vowel qualities of Maithili as sources of sonic pleasure. From the rasa-theory perspective, śṛṅgāra and karuṇā are again the dominant rasas, but śānta appears in the devotional poems with particular force. The biraha (longing, separation) theme — central to the Maithili lyric tradition from Vidyapati onwards — is present in the love poems but transformed: the beloved in Nand's biraha poetry is not merely the romantic other but, as dhvani analysis reveals, also the homeland left behind by the migrant, the language threatened by homogenization, the community disrupted by modernity.

## XIII. Critical Appreciation: Children's Literature (Swarn Kamal)

Swarn Kamal ('Golden Lotus', 2019, 54 pages, ₹150) is described on its title page as 'A Novel for Children in Maithili' — a genre that receives very little sustained critical attention in Maithili literary scholarship but whose cultural importance for language maintenance and transmission is immense. The

colophon notes that the story draws on the 'Swarna Kamal' folk-tale tradition (referencing a 1974 source), situating the novel within the living folk-tale heritage of Mithila.

The preface establishes the novel's narrative structure: a children's adventure involving the quest for a golden lotus, drawing on Maithili folk figures, natural settings (rivers, forests, village landscapes), and moral themes appropriate for young readers. The narrative technique is deliberately accessible — short chapters, active dialogue, clear causality, vivid sensory detail — while the folk-tale framework allows for the magical elements (talking animals, enchanted objects, supernatural helpers) that the genre traditionally employs.

From the aucitya (propriety) perspective, Swarn Kamal demonstrates skilled genre calibration: the language is calibrated for child readers without condescension, the moral themes are present but not didactically heavy-handed, and the adventure plot generates genuine narrative excitement. From the cultural-political perspective, a high-quality children's novel in Maithili is itself a political act: it makes the language desirable and exciting for young readers who might otherwise encounter it only in ceremonial or educational contexts. Nand's contribution to Maithili children's literature complements the work of other Videha-recognized children's writers (Preeti Thakur's Maithili Chitrakatha) in the project of building a complete literary culture.

## XIV. Critical Appreciation: Village Memory (Gaamghar)

Gaamghar ('Village Home' or 'The Home Village', 58 pages) is the earliest of Nand's texts in terms of composition — a note on the cover indicates that a version received an award in 1991, making this the work that establishes his literary credentials and earliest public recognition. The title Gaamghar combines 'gaam' (village/grama) and 'ghar' (home/house) to evoke the specifically Maithili concept of the village-home as both physical place and social identity — not merely where one lives but what one is.

The preface and opening pages present Gaamghar as a lyrical prose meditation on village life, memory, and belonging — a genre that sits between the memoir and the prose poem, between the ethnographic sketch and the personal essay. The village is not sentimentalized as a lost paradise: Nand's prose renders its social complexity with the same critical intelligence that informs his social

novels. But it is also represented as a repository of experience, relationship, and cultural knowledge that the modern world threatens to erase.

The genre of the village-memory text has deep roots in Maithili literature — from Nagarjun/Yatri's prose pieces about the Mithila countryside to Harimohan Jha's evocations of village social life. Nand's Gaamghar connects this tradition to the contemporary moment: written in the early 1990s and then preserved and published through the Gosauni Baidyanath Smriti Manch, it bridges the generation of the Nagarjun era and the contemporary Videha moment.

## XV. Themes, Language, and Prosody Across the Corpus

### 15.1 Recurring Themes

Across all twelve texts, five major thematic clusters recur with sufficient regularity to constitute the intellectual signature of Nand's corpus:

Social marginalization and its politics: From the 'lone dog' of Anthiya Kukur through the Delhi migrant of Dillik Park to the village protagonist of Gudrik Lal, Nand consistently centres characters who occupy structurally marginal positions — too educated for the village, too poor for the city; too modern for tradition, too traditional for modernity. This marginality is never romanticized; it is rendered as a specific set of social conditions with specific material and psychological consequences.

Family memory and its fragility: Parivar and Gaamghar represent the poles of this theme, but it permeates the social novels and even the children's fiction. The family — its internal hierarchies, its affections, its repressions, and its moments of grace — is Nand's primary social unit of analysis.

Women's inner life and social constraint: From Kaikeyi through Sujata and Sukanya to the female characters of Adambar and Anthiya Kukur, Nand returns repeatedly to women who are rendered as full moral agents but who operate within severe structural constraints. His feminist literary practice is consistent without being programmatic.

The relationship between tradition and modernity: Nearly every text in the corpus stages, in some form, the negotiation between inherited Maithili cultural forms and the disruptions of contemporary life — migration, education,

technology, economic pressure. This negotiation is never resolved into a simple narrative of loss or progress but is maintained as a productive tension.

The village as both home and limitation: Gaamghar, Anthiya Kukur, and Gudrik Lal constitute a sustained meditation on the village not as a nostalgic ideal but as a real social environment with both sustaining community and crushing constraint. This is the democratic realism that connects Nand to the best tradition of Maithili social fiction.

### 15.2 Language

Nand writes in contemporary colloquial Maithili of the Darbhanga variety — accessible to a broad Maithili readership while preserving the idiomatic specificity of the Darbhanga region. His language avoids both the heavy Sanskritization of traditional literary Maithili and the excessive Hindicization of some contemporary writers. The dialogues are particularly strong: characters speak in a Maithili that is immediately recognizable as alive, vernacular, and socially differentiated — different social positions speak different registers of Maithili.

### 15.3 Prosody and Form

In Kavya Sarita, Nand employs both traditional mātrā-based Maithili verse forms and free verse. His traditional verses show command of the prosodic system, while his free verse demonstrates an ear for the natural rhythms of Maithili speech. In his prose, he favours medium-length sentences with active verbs, regular paragraph breaks, and dialogue-heavy scene construction — a style that reads well both silently and aloud, facilitating the oral performance contexts in which Maithili literary culture still flourishes.

## XVI. Comparative Placement within Maithili Literary History

The Videha Parallel History identifies the major landmarks of democratic Maithili literary tradition: the Buddhist Charyapadas (8th–12th century), Vidyapati's Padavali (14th–15th century), Harimohan Jha's anti-caste social satires (1908–1984), Nagarjun/Yatri's village prose and poetry, Rajkamal Chaudhary's avant-garde fiction, and the contemporary generation anchored by Jagdish Prasad Mandal, Rajdeo Mandal, and Bechan Thakur.

Nand Kumar Mishra 'Nand' does not occupy the highest tier of this hierarchy — but hierarchy is not the appropriate framework for evaluating a productive democratic literary culture. His significance lies precisely in his breadth: twelve texts across six genres, all produced under a regional imprint without institutional support, all grounded in the social reality of Mithila village and diaspora life, all demonstrating formal competence and genuine literary purpose. Where Jagdish Prasad Mandal represents the deepest engagement with Dalit-subaltern experience, and Bechan Thakur the most radical theatrical intervention, Nand represents the middle range of the democratic literary tradition: the productive, formally competent, socially engaged writer who builds the bulk of the literary culture that famous individual peaks depend upon.

The closest comparison in the Maithili tradition is with writers like Trilokanath Mishra (Ranjana) or Shashikant (Girahkatta, Akasadeepa) — writers who have produced sustained bodies of work across multiple genres without achieving the canonical recognition that institutional gatekeepers confer. In international terms, Nand's combination of social realism, mythological revision, memoiristic prose, and children's fiction suggests a comparison with regional writers in other Indian languages who have similarly produced broad, genre-diverse corpora in service of their linguistic community: the 'workhorses' of literary culture, whose contribution is indispensable even when it is overlooked.

The Navya-Nyāya demand for avacchedaka precision in critical evaluation requires that this comparative placement be specified: Nand is significant within the category of 'productive mid-range democratic Maithili prose writers of the early 21st century', not in the category of 'transformative singular literary genius'. Within the first category, his corpus — twelve texts, six genres, sustained social engagement, formal diversity — marks him as a leading figure. This is honest critical evaluation, not a diminishment.

## XVII. Conclusion

Nand Kumar Mishra 'Nand' emerges from this study as a significant and productive contributor to the democratic tradition of Maithili literature — a writer whose twelve published texts between 2011 and 2022 constitute one of the most substantial individual prose corpora in contemporary Maithili writing outside the institutional mainstream. His social novels (Anthiya Kukur, Sukanya, Gudrik Lal), mythological retellings (Kaikeyi, Sujata), memoiristic

novel (Parivar), short-story collection (Adambar), literary sketches (Dillik Park, Yachak ke Nai), poetry (Kavya Sarita), children's novel (Swarn Kamal), and village memoir (Gaamghar) collectively demonstrate formal range, social intelligence, and sustained literary purpose.

Assessed through the Indian critical framework of rasa-dhvani-vakrokti-aucitya: his dominant rasas (karuṇā, śānta, śṛṅgāra) are deployed with consistency and control; his best titles and passages achieve genuine dhvani (Anthiya Kukur, Adambar, Swarn Kamal); his literary sketches deploy vakrokti as their primary mode; and his genre calibration demonstrates aucitya across the full range of forms he employs. Assessed through the Western critical frameworks: his social novels achieve the Aristotelian unity of action and Chekhovian social observation; his mythological retellings participate in the international tradition of feminist mythological revision; his sketches demonstrate Formalist integration; and his positioning as a Mithila-diaspora writer makes him available for postcolonial hybridity analysis.

The Navya-Nyāya epistemological demand — that all critical claims be made with avacchedaka precision on the basis of the four pramāṇas — has been applied throughout this study: direct textual reading (Pratyakṣa) through all twelve books; critical inference (Anumāna) from textual detail to general claims, with the inferential logic specified; comparative placement (Upamāna) within the Maithili tradition and against international comparanda; and primary-source testimony (Śabda) through the author's own prefaces and colophons.

The Videha Parallel History Framework's most important contribution is structural: it reminds us that Nand's twelve books, published by a regional Darbhanga institution with no institutional literary machinery behind them, represent an act of cultural persistence against the grain of a literary establishment that has systematically excluded non-establishment voices. His work is the living tissue of the parallel literary tradition — not its most celebrated peaks but its essential, sustaining body.

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's own story — the philosopher who achieved the greatest intellectual accomplishment of his age while born outside conventional legitimacy and married across caste — is the symbolic frame for understanding Nand's creative situation: the writer who produces twelve substantial texts without institutional recognition, whose contribution to Maithili literary culture is real and lasting precisely because it is grounded in the social reality that institutional culture systematically overlooks. The Tattvacintāmaṇi's demand for pramāṇa-based knowledge — suppress no testimony, specify your claims,

know on the basis of evidence — is both a philosophical instruction and an ethical one. This study has attempted to honour it.

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**ADDENDUM**

**The Epistemological Realism of the Subaltern: A Critical Appreciation of Nand Kumar Mishra ‘Nand’**

**Nand Kumar Mishra ‘Nand’ is a pivotal figure in the Videha Parallel History Movement, representing the transition of Maithili literature from the "mechanical age" to the "electronic and internet age." His work constitutes a "Life-Witness" (*Jeevan-Saakshi*) that resists institutionalized narratives through a commitment to subaltern realism and linguistic authenticity. This report offers a comprehensive critical appreciation of his bibliography, applying the Navya-Nyāya epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya alongside Indian and Western critical theories.**

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**I. Theoretical Framework: Logic as a Witness**

**1. Navya-Nyāya Epistemology (Gaṅgeśa’s Technique)**

**In the Videha critical project, Navya-Nyāya is not merely a philosophy but a rigorous tool for literary analysis. Mishra’s realism is treated as *pramāṇa* (valid knowledge) using:**

- **Avacchedaka (Delimitor): Identifying the specific socio-economic properties (caste, poverty, urban alienation) that delimit a character’s identity.**
- **Abhāva (Absence): Analyzing the "absence" of resources or justice as a real, causal agent (*nimitta*) in the plot.**
- **Śābdabodha (Verbal Understanding): Evaluating how Mishra’s use of the "oral register" tracks the external world accurately rather than creating mere mental fabrications.**

**2. Videha Parallel History Framework**

**Mishra’s works are analyzed as a "Parallel History" that reclaims the voices of the marginalized—voices often filtered out by the "dried main drain" of official institutional gatekeepers. His position as a participant-observer lends his narratives documentary authority.**

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**II. Detailed Critical Appreciation of Major Books**

**1. Children's Literature: *Swarn Kamal* (स्वर्ण कमल)**

**As a children's novel (*Bal Upanyas*), *Swarn Kamal* represents Mishra's effort to recreationalize folk motifs for a younger audience within a logically structured framework.**

- **Navya-Nyāya Analysis: Even in the realm of the "imaginary," Mishra maintains a precision of definition (*saṅgati*). The protagonist's journey is analyzed through the *avacchedaka* of heroic virtue, where every obstacle is a specific counter-positive (*pratiyogin*) to the "absence" of equilibrium in the story's world.**
- **Reader-Response and Folk Realism: Applying Reader-Response Theory, Mishra uses the Maithili oral register to structure the cognitive development of children. The "Golden Lotus" serves as a suggestion (*Dhvani*) for cultural purity and resilience against social decay.**

**2. Novels of Subaltern Realism**

- **Gudarik Lal (गुदरीक लाल, 2008): Meaning "a gem in the rags," this novel is a cornerstone of the Maithili subaltern breakthrough. Through Marxist Realism, Mishra establishes causal links between the "crippled agricultural system" and the migration of labor. In Navya-Nyāya terms, the *absence* (*abhāva*) of rural opportunity is the efficient cause (*nimitta*) of the protagonist's displacement.**

  **Anathiya Kukur (अनठिया कुकुर): This novel explores urban alienation. The metaphor of the "unclaimed dog" represents the ontological status of the migrant in a metropolis, characterized by an absolute absence (*atyantābhāva*) of identity and belonging.**

- **Sujata (सुजाता, 2006): A novel focusing on social morality and gender. Using Feminist Theory, Mishra analyzes the character Sujata via the *avacchedakas* of patriarchal constraints. Her suffering is presented as a delimited property of the Mithila landscape.**

**3. Portraits of Social Morality and Hypocrisy**

- **Sukanya (सुकन्या): Continues the exploration of gendered agency, depicting the individual's struggle within traditional social hierarchies.**
- **Parivar (परिवार): A "memoir-novel" (*sansmaran-atmak upanyas*) depicting the psychological realism of the disintegration of the Maithili family unit. It utilizes Sociological Criticism to document the decay of trust and socio-economic stability in domestic settings.**
- **Adambar (आडम्बर): A story collection targeting social hypocrisy. Mishra uses Vakrokti (striking/oblique satire) to expose the false pretensions of the rural and urban elite.**

**4. Diaspora and Marginalized "Word-Pictures"**

- **Dillika Park (दिल्लीक पार्क): These word-pictures (*shabd-chitra*) serve as a witness for the Maithili diaspora in Delhi, documenting urban migration with "autobiographical warmth."**
- **Yachak Ke Nanhi (याचक के नञि): A series of word-pictures humanizing the "beggar" or the marginalized. Through Subaltern Theory, Mishra provides documentary authority to lives traditionally viewed with disgust (*Vibhatsa*), converting them into objects of compassion (*Karuna Rasa*).**
- **Gaamghar (गामघर): A collection of stories capturing the decay of the rural landscape and the pathos of those left behind.**

**5. Poetry and Revisionist Prose**

- **Maharani Kaikeyi (महारानी कैकेयी): A discursive essay reinterpreting the Ramayana myth. Mishra employs Post-Colonial Myth-Criticism to dismantle the "exclusionary cultural identity" imposed on Kaikeyi, using Dhvani to suggest her complex, selfless motivations.**
- **Kavya Sarita (काव्य सरिता): A poetry collection characterized by linguistic authenticity and the use of the "oral register." It reflects the transition from classical Vedic meters to modern Maithili speech rhythms.**

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**III. Comparative Critical Synthesis**

| Work Type | Theoretical Lens | Navya-Nyāya Category | Aesthetic Rasa |
|---|---|---|---|
| Children's Fiction (*Swarn Kamal*) | Cognitive Theory | *Saṅgati* (Relevance) | *Adbhut* (Wonder) |
| Subalter | Marxism | *Nimitta* | *Karuna* |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| **n Novels (*Gudari k Lal*)** | | **(Efficient Cause)** | **(Compassion)** |
| **Satirical Stories (*Adambar*)** | ***Vakrokti*** | ***Anumāna* (Inference)** | ***Hasya* (Satire)** |
| **Mythical Essays (*Kaikeyi*)** | **Revisionism** | ***Śābdabodha* (Understanding)** | ***Shanta* (Tranquility)** |

**IV. Conclusion: Cultural Justice through Logic**

**Nand Kumar Mishra ‘Nand’ exemplifies the modern Maithili intellectual who reconciles the logical rigor of ancient Mithila with visceral folk expression. By applying Gaṅgeśa’s methodology to subaltern experiences, his work serves as a "whetstone for gold" in the pursuit of truth. His bibliography is not merely fiction but a set of "knowledges" (*viśiṣṭajñāna*) that map the real structure of the Maithili world, ensuring that the witness of the marginalized remains a powerful, present reality in the ongoing parallel history of Mithila.**

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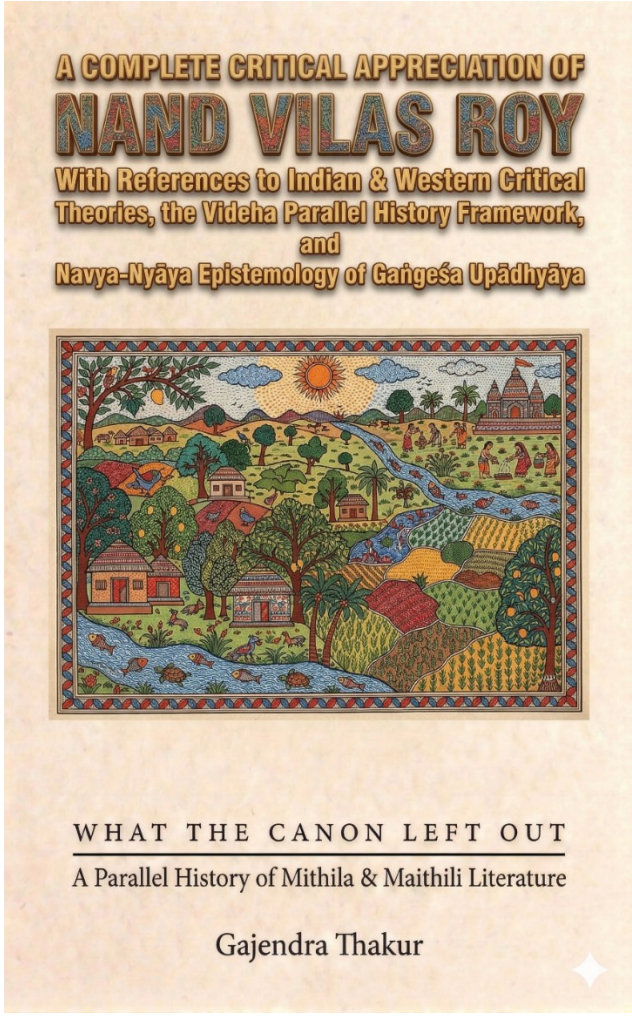
**LESSON 051 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**




# A COMPLETE CRITICAL APPRECIATION OF

# NAND VILAS ROY

*With References to Indian & Western Critical Theories,*
*the Videha Parallel History Framework,*
*and Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya*


## Abstract

Nand Vilas Roy (b. Bhapatiyahi, Madhubani, Bihar) is among the most significant voices in contemporary Maithili parallel literature. A prolific writer of short fiction (kathā), seed stories (bīhani kathā), and poetry, he has published over a dozen collections including Sakhārī-Peṭārī (2013; 2nd ed. 2024), Assal Pūjā (2022), Marjādāk Bhoj (2018), Bhārdutiyā (2018), Chhāthik Dālā (2018), Hamār Chārudhām (2018), and Madan-Amar. His work is published exclusively through Pallavi Prakashan, Nirmali, and is archived in the Videha e-Journal (ISSN 2229-547X). This critical appreciation applies Indian classical theories (Dhvani, Rasa), Western theories (Formalism, New Criticism, Marxism, Postcolonialism, Subaltern Studies), the Videha Parallel History Framework advanced by Gajendra Thakur, and the epistemological techniques of Navya-Nyāya logician Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya to assess Roy's literary corpus. The study argues that Roy exemplifies what the Videha movement calls the 'democratic parallel tradition': a literature of the subaltern, rooted in Maithili rural reality, structurally opposed to the Brahminical establishment canon, and formally experimental through its mastery of the bīhani kathā mode.


## I. Biographical and Contextual Introduction

### 1.1 Life and Background

Nand Vilas Roy was born and raised in Bhapatiyahi, Madhubani District, Bihar — the heartland of Mithila, the ancient kingdom whose literary, philosophical, and cultural traditions stretch from the Brhadāraṇyaka Upaniṣad dialogues of King Janaka to the logical revolution of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya. Roy belongs to the generation of Maithili writers who came to maturity in the digital age and

found their literary home in the Videha parallel movement rather than in the Sahitya Akademi establishment apparatus.

In the prefatory note to Assal Pūjā (2022), Roy writes candidly about the material conditions of writing in the margins: 'Those who are engaged in the struggle for salt, oil and firewood throughout the day find literary creation doubly difficult.' This honest self-positioning — the author as economic subject, not a leisured upper-caste intellectual — is itself a political-aesthetic statement. It aligns him with the democratic-subaltern tradition that the Videha Parallel History Framework identifies as the true mainstream of Maithili literary production, historically suppressed by Brahminical establishment gatekeepers.

His mentors include Dr. Ramchandra Rai (Shanti Niketan, Bolpur), Dr. Umesh Mandal, Dr. Yogananda Jha, and Prof. Dhirendra Kumar — all associated with the progressive-democratic wing of Maithili letters. His publisher is Pallavi Prakashan, Nirmali, which functions as an alternative institutional infrastructure to the New Delhi-based houses that dominate Sahitya Akademi-recognised publishing.

## 1.2 The Videha Parallel Literature Movement: Framework for Situating Roy

The Videha Parallel History Framework, as theorised and documented by Gajendra Thakur in the ongoing Parallel History of Mithila and Maithili Literature (videha.co.in/gajenthakur.htm), distinguishes sharply between two streams of Maithili literary tradition: the mainstream or establishment canon — Brahmin-centred, Sahitya Akademi-anointed, casteist in its selection principles — and the parallel or democratic tradition, which recovers suppressed voices from Buddhist Charyapadas through Harimohan Jha's anti-caste satirical novels, Rajkamal Chaudhary's avant-garde fiction, Jagdish Prasad Mandal's subaltern novels (finally awarded Sahitya Akademi 2021), and contemporary writers such as Roy.

The Parallel History Framework insists, following T.K. Oommen's sociological analysis (Sociology, 1988, p. 291), that the Maithili literary field is economically and culturally dominated by Brahmins, and that the Sahitya Akademi mechanism — its recognised literary organisations, its advisory board composition — systematically excludes non-Brahmin, lower-caste, and subaltern voices. Nand Vilas Roy's entire literary career unfolds within and against this structure of exclusion: his themes, forms, characters, and publishers all mark his work as part of the democratic-parallel tradition.

A crucial precursor figure illuminated by the Parallel History is Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (c. 1300–1350 CE), the Maithili philosopher-logician. The Videha research recovered from the Dūṣaṇa Pañjī (the genealogical record of social 'flaws') that Gaṅgeśa was born five years after his father's death and married a Charmakāriṇī — facts suppressed by mainstream historians including Prof. Ramanath Jha. The significance for literary criticism is epistemological: if even the supreme logician of Mithila was of marginalised social origin, and that fact was erased, how much more thoroughly have the literary voices of the margins been suppressed?

## II. The Corpus: Works, Forms, and Publication History

### 2.1 The Short Story Collections

Roy's primary literary form is the Maithili short story (kathā) and seed story (bīhani kathā). His published collections are:

Sakhārī-Peṭārī ('The Seed-Chest') — First published by Shruti Prakashan, New Delhi, 2013; Second edition, Pallavi Prakashan, Nirmali, 2024. ISBN 978-93-93135-92-6. The title itself is culturally dense: sakhārī-peṭārī is the chest of life-sustaining household goods given to a daughter at marriage — rice, oil, spices, utensils — the material kit for wifely survival. Roy's metaphor recontextualises this: his stories are the gifts placed in the chest to equip readers for life. The collection contains fourteen stories including 'Assal Beṭā' ('The Real Son'), 'Tabāhat' ('Ruin'), 'Niwās Pramāṇ Patra' ('Residence Certificate'), 'Mahājan', and others.

Assal Pūjā ('Real Worship') — Pallavi Prakashan, 2022. ISBN 978-93-93135-27-8. A short-story anthology focussing on themes of authentic religious practice versus social performance, caste discrimination, and economic survival. The prefatory note 'Kichhu Apan Bāt' ('A Few Personal Words') is itself a document of subaltern authorial self-positioning.

Marjādāk Bhoj ('The Feast of Dignity') — Pallavi Prakashan, 2018. ISBN 978-93-87675-55-1. A collection of short stories structured around social rituals — meals, ceremonies, performances — that either affirm or violate human dignity.

Bhārdutiyā — Pallavi Prakashan, 2018. ISBN 978-93-88421-83-6. Dedicated to his late parents Vankhari Roy and Durga Devi, and to his brother Anjani Kumar Roy, nephews Veer and Dheer, children Karan and Vandana.

Madan-Amar — A collection of Maithili seed stories (the title story being the most celebrated). ISBN not independently listed; published through Pallavi Prakashan infrastructure.

## 2.2 The Poetry Collections

Roy has published two anthologies of Maithili poetry and song: Chhāthik Dālā ('The Chhath Basket') — Pallavi Prakashan, 2018. ISBN 978-93-87675-77-3. Poetry centred on the Chhath festival — the great autumnal sun worship of Bihar and the Mithila region, observed especially by the agrarian and lower castes. The collection is explicitly dedicated in its paratextual address to the democratic Maithili reading public.

Hamār Chārudhām ('Our Four Pilgrimages') — Pallavi Prakashan, 2018. ISBN 978-93-88421-86-7. A poetic reimagining of the concept of sacred pilgrimage (chārudhām) in terms of the ordinary rural life of Mithila rather than the Brahminical-sanskritic sacred geography.

## 2.3 The Bīhani Kathā Form

A formal innovation central to Roy's work is the Maithili bīhani kathā — the 'seed story'. As theorised in the Videha Parallel History (Part 32: 'Maithili Bīhani Kathā: The Seed Story Tradition'), this form is 'a micronarrative form unique to Maithili literature that has no direct equivalent in other Indian literary languages' and 'not simply a compressed short story but a genetically distinct form shaped by Maithili oral tradition, the pragmatics of digital dissemination, and the ideological commitments of democratic and subaltern literary practice.' Roy's 'Madan-Amar' — the title story of his seed-story collection — is among the most cited examples of the genre. The bīhani kathā 'aspires to the condition of the seed: complete in itself, self-contained, yet carrying within its brevity the potential fullness of a much larger narrative.' The ending that 'opens rather than closes' is the formal hallmark.

# III. Thematic Analysis

## 3.1 Caste, Class, and Social Discrimination

The thematic backbone of Roy's fiction is the experience of caste and class discrimination in rural Mithila. 'Madan-Amar', his signature seed story, opens with a child, Madan, being taken by his friend Ammar to his upper-caste maternal grandmother's haveḷī. The grandmother — on discovering Ammar is the son of Bhola Chaupāl, a lower-caste family — expels the child with the words: 'Khatabaiye jātik chhaurrā ke haveḷī bhitar analah' ('You brought a child of the Khatab caste into the mansion?'). The narrative fast-forwards: years later, Ammar has become a Block Development Officer; Madan, now his subordinate clerk, realises the identity. The story ends with the two men embracing — the powerful official and the subaltern child now reversed, the class hierarchy and the caste hierarchy pulled apart.

This narrative structure — the child's humiliation, the adult reversal — encodes what the Videha Parallel History calls the democratic counter-movement: the story refuses the elite's claim to social authority by demonstrating merit's independence from caste birth. In Marxist critical terms (Lukács' concept of 'type'), the story creates a social-typical confrontation between the old feudal-caste order and the new meritocratic-democratic order, rendered not through abstract debate but through affective, embodied incident.

In 'Assal Beṭā' ('The Real Son'), Roy narrates the life of Jīvan Mukhiyā, a fisherman by caste who has abandoned his caste occupation to run a tea stall at Nirmali station. Against social odds, he educates his children to become engineers and a teacher. When he dies, it is his daughter Suknī — who remained home to care for him — who performs the rituals of filial devotion. His successful sons, though wealthy, arrive late. The schoolmaster Gopal observes at the end that the true sons are those who perform care, not those who achieve status. The story critiques Brahminical notions of ritual obligation (filial duty defined by son, not daughter) while simultaneously celebrating a low-caste man's aspiration and achievement.

## 3.2 Women, Patriarchy, and Agency

A persistent concern in Roy's fiction is the gendered structure of Maithili rural society and the forms of agency women assert within it. In 'Diyā' (from Madan-Amar), a young woman named Diyā — daughter of a farmer, studying B.Ed. in Rajeviraj (Nepal) — is caught in a marriage negotiation where her prospective

father-in-law demands four lakh Nepali rupees as bribe to secure his son's government posting. The story's structural concern is the trap: a young woman's autonomy is mortgaged to male economic corruption at every level — her father's poverty, the prospective groom's father's greed, the bureaucratic bribery system. Roy's narrative sympathy is explicitly with Diyā and her parents; the corrupt father-in-law is rendered with diagnostic precision but no melodrama.

Roy's poetry collections — Chhāthik Dālā and Hamār Chārudhām — also consistently foreground women's religiosity and women's labour in ways that affirm the dignity of non-Brahminical, folk-based spiritual practice. The Chhath festival, celebrated with extraordinary devotion primarily by lower-caste and agrarian women, is the poetic universe of Chhāthik Dālā — a deliberate reclamation of sacred space from Brahminical monopoly.

## 3.3 Migration, Displacement, and the Rural-Urban Fracture

A third major thematic cluster concerns the migration of Bihari/Maithili men to urban centres (Mumbai, Delhi, Dhanbad) and the social and familial fractures this produces. Roy's Mithila is not the timeless pastoral of the Sahitya Akademi establishment's preferred imagery. It is a space of permanent economic crisis: children leaving for cities, old parents abandoned, families dissolved, the social fabric of the village fraying under market pressure.

The structure of 'Assal Beṭā' explicitly maps this: Jīvan's sons become engineers in Mumbai and Delhi; they send money but are absent for their dying father. The daughter, who stays, who performs the actual labour of care, is the one without institutional recognition. Roy's narrative geometry — the successful migrants versus the staying daughter — is both sociologically precise and emotionally devastating.

## 3.4 Authenticity (Assal) as Ethical Concept

The word assal — 'real', 'authentic', 'genuine' — recurs significantly in Roy's titles and themes: Assal Pūjā ('Real Worship'), 'Assal Beṭā' ('The Real Son'). This lexical choice constitutes a consistent philosophical project. Against performance (performative piety, performative filial duty, performative upper-caste status), Roy's fiction valorises the authentic: real care, real devotion, real solidarity. This is not naïve realism but an ethical-aesthetic stance — what the Indian dhvani tradition would recognise as the vyañjanā (suggestive resonance) of the word 'real', which simultaneously indicts its opposite (the fake, the performed, the status-driven).

# IV. Formal and Structural Analysis

## 4.1 Narrative Structure and the 'Seed Logic' of the Bīhani Kathā

The Russian Formalist concept of siuzhet (plot arrangement as distinct from fabula or story) is illuminating for Roy's bīhani kathā. The seed story characteristically compresses a long fabula — years of social history, entire lifetimes of aspiration and humiliation — into a minimal siuzhet of dramatic scene, reversal, and resonant ending. In 'Madan-Amar', the fabula spans childhood friendship, caste expulsion, years of study and struggle, government employment, and a workplace reunion; the siuzhet presents only the crucial points — the haveḷī scene (backstory compressed into reported speech) and the office reunion scene (the present moment).

The ending of 'Madan-Amar' is a formal masterpiece of what the Videha criticism calls 'seed logic — an ending that opens rather than closes meaning': the two men embrace; Madan weeps; no moral is stated. The paratactic narrative refuses didacticism, trusting the reader's inference capacity. This is a technique aligned with the New Critical concept of 'affective fallacy' avoidance: the emotion is produced by the structure, not by authorial sentimentality.

In longer kathā like 'Assal Beṭā', Roy uses what Shklovsky would recognise as defamiliarization (ostranenie): the caste identity of Jīvan Mukhiyā (fisherman) is established quietly in the opening paragraphs and then systematically forgotten by the narrative — until the moment Gopal's judgment ('You are his real sons') reopens the question of what 'real' sonhood means. The defamiliarization is of the category 'son' itself.

## 4.2 Language, Register, and Linguistic Politics

Roy writes exclusively in Maithili, using the spoken dialectal registers of northern Bihar and Madhubani district rather than the sanskritised literary Maithili preferred by establishment writers. This linguistic choice is itself politically significant: as the Videha Parallel History documents, the Sahitya Akademi establishment historically privileged Brahminical high-register Maithili, which T.K. Oommen identifies as one mechanism of cultural domination that 'adversely affects the development of several languages'.

The speech of Roy's characters — tea-stall owners, farmers, station masters, Block Development Officers — is rendered in socially differentiated registers. Station Master Anil Chatterjee's Maithili (in 'Assal Beṭā') has Bengali-inflected traces; Jīvan's speech is the Maithili of the uneducated agrarian labouring class; the narrative voice modulates between these registers with great sophistication. This polyphony recalls Bakhtin's concept of heteroglossia — the novel as space of competing social voices, none authorised as 'correct'.

### 4.3 The Titles as Para-textual Meaning Generators

Roy's titles function as dense meaning-nodes that operate as what Gérard Genette calls 'paratextual' frames. Sakhārī-Peṭārī invokes the complete material kit of a Maithili bride — goods for survival, not luxuries. The implicit claim: literature, like the marriage chest, should equip for life, not decorate it. Chhāthik Dālā (the ritual Chhath basket) invokes a non-Brahminical sacred practice and its female practitioners. Hamār Chārudhām claims the sacred geography of ordinary rural life as pilgrimage. Each title is a reclamation — of cultural authority, of sacred space, of the definition of 'real' value.

## V. Application of Critical Frameworks

### 5.1 Indian Classical Theories

#### *5.1.1 Rasa Theory (Bharata, Abhinavagupta)*

Bharata's Nāṭyaśāstra posits eight primary rasas (aesthetic emotions) evoked in the reader-spectator through bhāvas (emotional states) depicted in the work. The dominant rasa of Roy's fiction is karuṇa (compassion-grief), consistently evoked through the portrayal of the poor, the dispossessed, and the socially humiliated. The bhāvas of poverty, filial devotion, caste humiliation, and subaltern aspiration are rendered with affective precision. Abhinavagupta's extension of rasa theory (Abhinavabhāratī) insists that the experience of rasa requires sādhāraṇīkaraṇa — a universalisation of the particular experience that allows aesthetic distance. Roy's spare, non-sentimental narrative style performs precisely this universalisation: the reader experiences Jīvan's death not as melodrama but as sorrow-with-dignity.

The rasa of vīra (heroism) is subtly present in Roy's portrayal of subaltern aspiration: Jīvan Mukhiyā's determination to educate his children against

economic odds, Ammar's journey from expelled child to BDO, Diyā's resistance to corrupt marriage conditions. These are everyday heroisms, not epic ones — which accords with the democratic-parallel tradition's preference for mundane over mythological heroism.

### *5.1.2 Dhvani Theory (Ānandavardhana)*

Ānandavardhana's Dhvanyāloka (c. 850 CE) posits dhvani — resonance, suggestion — as the 'soul of poetry': the meaning that transcends the literal and the secondary (metaphorical) to create a third, resonant level of significance. Roy's use of the word assal ('real/authentic') throughout his corpus operates precisely at the dhvani level: its suggestive resonance — 'genuine' against 'performed', 'true' against 'false', 'lived' against 'ceremonial' — generates a comprehensive ethical critique of Maithili social performance without ever naming that critique explicitly. This is dhvani at the thematic level.

At the formal level, the endings of Roy's bīhani kathā are structured to produce maximum dhvani: the embrace of Madan and Ammar, with Madan weeping, says nothing and means everything. The tears suggest shame (for his grandmother's act), relief (that the caste humiliation is overcome), joy (reunion), and grief (for all the years of separation) simultaneously. This multiplicity is the dhvani function in narrative prose.

### *5.1.3 Vakrokti Theory (Kuntaka)*

Kuntaka's Vakroktijīvita (c. 10th century) identifies vakrokti — oblique, indirect, deviant expression — as the core poetic principle. Roy's narrative indirection is consistently vakroktic: he never states a moral, never editorialises about caste injustice, never instructs the reader. Instead, the oblique placement of detail — the 'soiled clothes' of Ammar when he is expelled from the haveḷī, the single coin Miśrājī places on Jīvan's cashbox before the land deal, the station master's solitary meals at a hotel — creates meaning through indirection. The oblique is always more potent than the direct in Roy's narrative rhetoric.

## 5.2 Western Critical Theories

### *5.2.1 Marxist Literary Criticism (Lukács, Eagleton, Williams)*

Georg Lukács' concept of the literary 'type' — a character who simultaneously represents an individual and a historical-social tendency — is fully applicable to Roy's protagonists. Jīvan Mukhiyā is not merely an individual tea-stall

owner; he is a type of the subaltern aspirant in post-Independence Bihar, negotiating the space between caste restriction and constitutional promise. Ammar is a type of the meritocratic counter-force to feudal privilege. Their stories are simultaneously personal and social-historical.

Terry Eagleton's emphasis on ideology in literary texts is relevant to Roy's relationship to Maithili literary ideology. Roy's texts embody a counter-ideology to the dominant Sahitya Akademi establishment canon: they valorise low-caste protagonists, female agency, subaltern aspiration, and the secular-democratic over the religious-Brahminical. Raymond Williams' concept of the 'structure of feeling' — the lived texture of social experience before it crystallises into formal ideology — is precisely what Roy's fiction captures: the felt experience of caste discrimination, economic precarity, and subaltern dignity in contemporary Mithila.

### *5.2.2 New Criticism: Close Reading and Organic Form*

New Critical close reading — attending to the literary text as an organic whole in which every element (word choice, structure, image, tone) contributes to unified meaning — reveals the extraordinary economy and precision of Roy's prose. In 'Madan-Amar', every element serves double duty: the setting (Nirmali station, the Videha movement's own publishing heartland) situates the story in the lived geography of the parallel tradition; the name Ammar (related to Arabic 'long life') against Madan (the god of love) creates a subcultural resonance about endurance and human affection overcoming social division; the BDO posting (Block Development Officer — a developmental-democratic state institution) makes the class-reversal not merely individual but structural.

### *5.2.3 Postcolonial and Subaltern Studies (Spivak, Bhabha, Guha)*

Gayatri Spivak's question 'Can the subaltern speak?' is answered differently by Roy's fiction and by Roy's fiction's existence as a published, archived literary corpus. Spivak argued that the subaltern — positioned outside the colonial and nationalist discourse systems — cannot represent herself without appropriating the discourse that excludes her. Roy's fiction navigates this differently: it uses the literary form itself (the kathā, the bīhani kathā) as a Maithili-indigenous form, published by a Maithili subaltern-democratic institution (Pallavi Prakashan) and archived in a Maithili parallel institution (Videha eJournal). The subaltern here does speak — but through indigenous institutional infrastructure, not by appropriation of the dominant discourse.

Homi Bhabha's concept of 'third space' — the liminal site where cultural meaning is negotiated between dominant and dominated — is visible in Roy's narrative geography. The tea stall at Nirmali station is a third space: between the village (tradition, caste hierarchy) and the railway (modernity, institutional power). Jīvan operates in this threshold, accumulating not just capital but social dignity, before finally securing a piece of land (the purchase of the mill plot) that anchors him in place and legitimacy.

Ranajit Guha's call for a history from below — recovering the experiences and agency of subaltern groups suppressed from elite nationalist historiography — finds its literary parallel in Roy's fiction, which recovers the experiences of fishermen, farmers, tea-stall owners, lower-caste students, and rural women from the silence of the Sahitya Akademi establishment canon. This is the literary equivalent of Guha's subaltern history, operating through narrative rather than archive.

### *5.2.4 Feminist and Gender Theory (Beauvoir, Butler, Mohanty)*

Simone de Beauvoir's analysis of woman as 'Other' — constituted as subordinate in relation to the masculine subject — illuminates Roy's female characters and their structural positioning. In 'Diyā', the protagonist is constituted as exchange-object in the marriage negotiation: her father's poverty, her suitor's father's greed, the bribery system — all define her future in relation to male economic transactions. Roy's narrative sympathy, however, exceeds this structural victimisation: Diyā is pursuing education, exercising agency within constrained conditions, resisting the reductive definition the marriage market imposes.

Judith Butler's concept of performativity — gender (and, by extension, caste) as constituted through repeated performance rather than innate essence — is visible in Roy's deconstruction of filial duty in 'Assal Beṭā'. The ritual performances of mourning by the sons (arriving by plane, weeping loudly) are performative in Butler's sense: they constitute their identity as 'sons' through the performance of grief. The daughter Suknī's actual care — the non-performative, daily, material labour of nursing — is the 'real' (assal) sonhood that the narrative valorises.

## 5.3 The Videha Parallel History Framework

The Videha Parallel History Framework, as developed by Gajendra Thakur through thirty-plus instalments at videha.co.in/gajenthakur.htm, provides the

most contextually precise framework for Roy's work. Three core concepts are especially operative:

First, the concept of the 'dried main drain' versus the 'living parallel stream'. The Sahitya Akademi establishment canon is characterised as a 'dried main drain' — institutionally powerful but literarily ossified. The parallel tradition — of which Roy is part — is the living stream, connected to oral tradition, subaltern experience, and formal experiment. Roy's bīhani kathā is the formal expression of this living stream: rooted in Maithili folk narrative economy (the brief tale at the domestic ritual), updated for digital dissemination.

Second, the concept of 'honour-killing of legacy' — the active suppression of uncomfortable biographical and literary truths for ideological purposes. Applied to living writers like Roy, this concept illuminates the mechanisms by which the Sahitya Akademi apparatus ignores writers from the parallel tradition, no matter how significant: they are not reviewed, not anthologised, not awarded. Roy's multiple published collections, his consistent critical recognition within the parallel tradition, and his archival presence in Videha constitute a counter-record.

Third, the concept of 'pramāṇa from below' — valid knowledge produced through means available to subaltern scholars (oral testimony, pañjī records, parallel archival work) rather than establishment institutional endorsement. Roy's fiction itself can be read as pramāṇa from below: it produces knowledge of subaltern Maithili social life that the establishment canon erases or distorts.

## 5.4 Navya-Nyāya Epistemology: Gaṅgeśa's Analytical Technique Applied to Literary Criticism

The application of Navya-Nyāya epistemological technique to literary criticism is perhaps the most distinctive and innovative dimension of this appreciation. Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's Tattvacintāmaṇi (c. 1300–1350 CE) — which, as the Videha Parallel History (Part 16) documents, inaugurated the Navya-Nyāya ('New Logic') tradition — developed a hyper-precise technical vocabulary for analysing the structure of valid cognition (pramā). Several Navya-Nyāya concepts are directly applicable to literary-critical analysis.

### *5.4.1 Pramāṇa and the Validity of Literary Knowledge*

Gaṅgeśa's central question is the pramāṇa — the valid means of knowing. The four pramāṇas are: pratyakṣa (perception), anumāna (inference), upamāna (analogy/comparison), and śabda (verbal testimony). Literary fiction, in this

epistemological framework, operates primarily through śabda (verbal testimony) and anumāna (inference). Roy's fiction produces valid knowledge of subaltern social life through śabda — the verbal testimony of his narrative — which the reader validates through anumāna: inference from the narrative's presented evidence to social truths.

Gaṅgeśa's distinction between svataḥ pramāṇya (intrinsic validity — the Mīmāṃsā view that knowledge is self-validating) and parataḥ pramāṇya (extrinsic validity — Gaṅgeśa's own Nyāya view that validity is established through successful practical engagement) is relevant to how we assess Roy's literary truth claims. Against the Mīmāṃsā-like assumption of the Sahitya Akademi establishment (that only Akademi-recognised works have intrinsic literary validity), the Navya-Nyāya approach insists that validity must be demonstrated through practical engagement (samvādipravṛtti): does the work successfully represent, illuminate, and communicate? Roy's works, judged by the practical criterion of reader recognition and critical engagement within the parallel tradition, demonstrate extrinsic validity.

### *5.4.2 Avacchedaka (Limitor) and Literary Specificity*

The most technically distinctive Navya-Nyāya concept is the avacchedaka — the 'limitor', a relational operator that specifies the precise scope of a cognition or property. For example, in Gaṅgeśa's analysis, the cognition 'there is fire on the hill' must be precisely specified: the hill-ness (parvatatva) limits the locus of the fire; the smoke-ness (dhūmatva) limits the inferential mark. Without the avacchedaka, cognition is ambiguous and inference is invalid.

Applied to literary criticism, the avacchedaka concept demands that we specify precisely what property we are attributing to a text, and what limits that attribution. For example: to say 'Roy's fiction is realistic' requires specification: realistic-ness as limited by (avacchinna by) the subaltern-rural-Maithili experience domain — not by the realistic conventions of metropolitan Hindi or English fiction. To say 'Roy's bīhani kathā is formally innovative' requires specification: innovative-ness as limited by the Maithili literary tradition (not by world flash fiction). The avacchedaka prevents the sloppy generalisation that comparative criticism often performs — importing metropolitan critical standards as unmarked universals.

### *5.4.3 Vyāpti (Pervasion) and Thematic Analysis*

The concept of vyāpti — invariable concomitance, the universal relation between inferential mark (hetu/liṅga) and what is inferred (sādhya) — is

operative in identifying the thematic constants of Roy's corpus. There is a strong vyāpti between 'Roy's stories featuring caste encounter' and 'Roy's stories ending with a democratic reversal or affirmation'. This is not coincidental: it is the structural-thematic constant — the vyāpti — that defines his literary project. Similarly, there is vyāpti between 'Roy's female characters' and 'the representation of constrained agency exercised with dignity': this is the invariable concomitance that defines his feminist-subaltern characterisation.

#### *5.4.4 Savikalpaka / Nirvikalpaka and Degrees of Critical Interpretation*

Gaṅgeśa's distinction between nirvikalpaka pratyakṣa (indeterminate perception — raw, pre-linguistic apprehension of an object without its qualifiers) and savikalpaka pratyakṣa (determinate perception — perception with qualifiers, categories, relations) maps onto distinctions in literary reading. A first reading of 'Madan-Amar' produces something like nirvikalpaka cognition: an emotionally apprehended event, a movement of feeling. Critical analysis performs savikalpaka cognition: it applies qualifiers (caste, class, form, tradition), relates the text to its context, and produces determinate literary knowledge.

Roy's bīhani kathā form is designed to work at both levels: the nirvikalpaka impact of the ending (the embrace, the tears) is the immediate aesthetic experience; the savikalpaka critical analysis reveals the social-historical structure beneath. This two-level operation — affective immediacy and intellectual depth — is what distinguishes the bīhani kathā from both the conventional short story (which tends toward savikalpaka explicitness) and the lyric poem (which tends toward nirvikalpaka opacity).

## VI. Comparative Positioning in Maithili Literary History

### 6.1 Roy and Harimohan Jha

Harimohan Jha (1908–1984), systematically denied the Sahitya Akademi Award despite being the most widely read Maithili novelist, is Roy's most significant predecessor in the democratic tradition. Jha's satirical mode — using upper-caste Maithili Brahmin characters to expose the absurdity and cruelty of caste orthodoxy — differs from Roy's realist mode; but both share the fundamental ethical commitment to democratic values and both were/are

excluded from establishment recognition. Roy is Jha's democratic inheritor in the register of realist short fiction rather than satirical novel.

### 6.2 Roy and Jagdish Prasad Mandal

Jagdish Prasad Mandal — finally awarded the Sahitya Akademi in 2021 for Pangu, after decades of parallel tradition recognition — is the novelist-scale version of Roy's project. Mandal's novels document lower-caste rural Mithila in long-form; Roy documents the same world in the compressed form of kathā and bīhani kathā. Together, they constitute a comprehensive fictional mapping of subaltern Maithili social experience at the novel and short-story scales respectively.

### 6.3 Roy and the Bīhani Kathā Tradition

Within the bīhani kathā tradition specifically, Roy is contemporaneous with the form's institutionalisation in Videha. The landmark anthology Videha Maithili Vihani Kathā (Videha Sadeha 5) establishes the genre's canon; Roy's work is among the contributions that define the genre's parameters. Critic Bijayendra Jha's 2025 article 'A Critical Analysis of Maithili Short Stories: Twenty First Century' and the Videha critical apparatus provide the contemporary critical framework within which Roy's bīhani kathā must be evaluated.

## VII. Evaluation and Conclusion

### 7.1 Strengths

Roy's primary literary strengths are: formal economy (the bīhani kathā ending that opens meaning rather than closing it); thematic consistency and depth (the sustained exploration of caste, class, gender, and aspiration without didacticism); linguistic authenticity (the representation of socially differentiated Maithili registers without homogenisation); and ethical commitment (the valorisation of subaltern dignity without sentimentalisation). His work is technically accomplished, socially necessary, and formally innovative within the Maithili literary tradition.

### 7.2 Critical Reservations

A rigorous critical assessment must also note limitations. Roy's fiction occasionally risks a schematic moral geography — the subaltern good, the

upper-caste or materially successful bad — that can simplify social complexity. The narrative reversals (subaltern child becomes BDO; tea-stall owner's children become engineers) risk what Eagleton might call a 'humanist' resolution to structurally produced social contradictions: the individual triumph over caste does not dissolve the caste system. Roy's strongest work (the tightest bīhani kathā) resists this schematism; his longer kathā occasionally succumbs to it.

## 7.3 Conclusion

Nand Vilas Roy is an important, underappreciated figure in contemporary Maithili literature — important precisely because he is systematically underappreciated by the establishment apparatus. Applying the full range of critical frameworks — Indian classical (Rasa, Dhvani, Vakrokti), Western (Marxism, New Criticism, Postcolonialism, Feminism, Subaltern Studies), the Videha Parallel History Framework, and the analytical precision of Navya-Nyāya epistemology — we arrive at a comprehensive assessment: Roy is a realist master of the subaltern Maithili experience, an innovative practitioner of the bīhani kathā form, and a consistent democratic counter-voice to the Brahminical establishment canon.

Applying the Navya-Nyāya avacchedaka with precision: Roy's literary significance is limited by (avacchinna by) the domain of the Maithili parallel-democratic tradition — within which it is substantial — and not yet fully registered in the broader pan-Indian or global literary field, where the conditions for valid cognition (pramāṇa) of his work are still being established. The vyāpti between 'significant Maithili democratic literature' and 'exclusion from establishment recognition' has held throughout the twentieth century; Roy's career is the latest instantiation of this invariable concomitance. Breaking that vyāpti — through critical scholarship like this appreciation, through the Videha archive, through Pallavi Prakashan's continued work — is the task of the present moment.

As Gaṅgeśa demonstrated: validity (pramāṇya) is not intrinsic — it must be established through practical engagement (samvādipravṛtti). This critical appreciation is one such engagement. The seed has been planted; the fruit will come.

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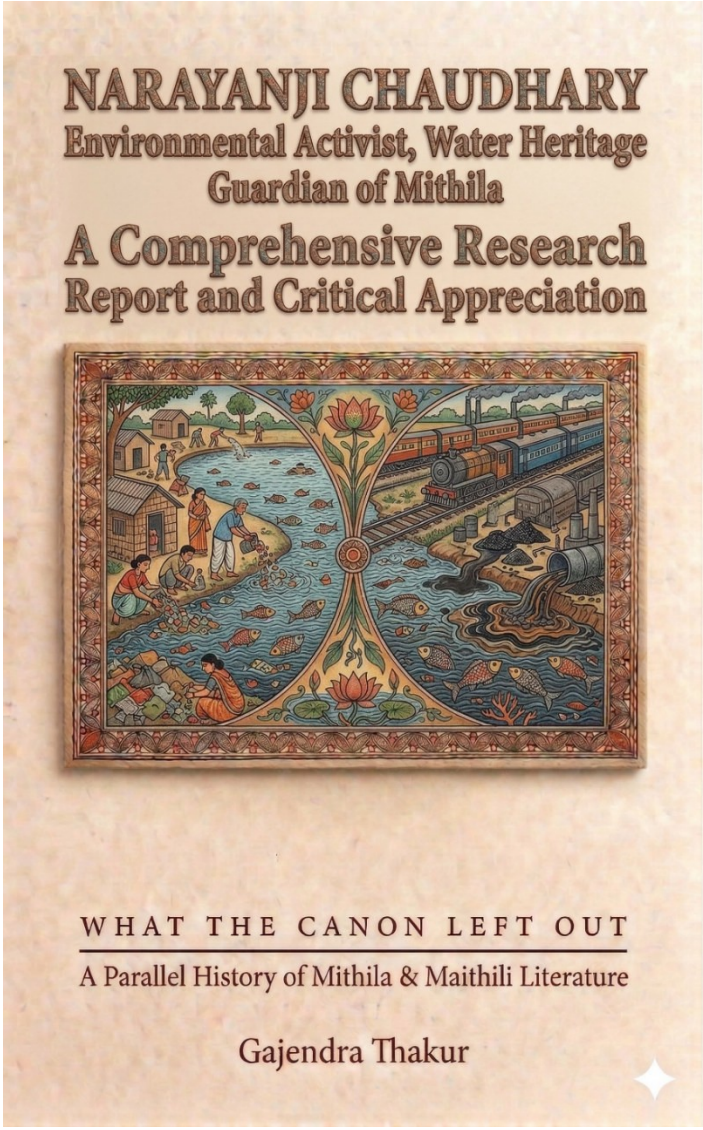


# NARAYANJI CHAUDHARY

*Environmental Activist, Water Heritage Guardian of Mithila*

*A Comprehensive Research Report and Critical Appreciation*

# 1. Introduction and Context

**Narayanji Chaudhary** (born 30 August 1959) is one of the most consequential grassroots environmental activists in contemporary Bihar. A native of Isahpur village, Pandaul, Madhubani district, he has devoted over two decades of his life to a singular, urgent mission: saving the traditional ponds (pokhars) and water bodies of the Mithila region from illegal encroachment, pollution, and administrative neglect. The Talab Bachao Abhiyan (Save Ponds Campaign) — the civil society movement he founded and leads through the Mithila Gram Vikas Parishad — has become one of the most cited examples of community-led water-body conservation in northern India.

Videha eJournal, the pioneering Maithili fortnightly digital journal (ISSN 2229-547X, founded 2000, www.videha.co.in), dedicated its 419th issue (01 June 2025) to Narayanji Chaudhary as a full *Visheshank* (special issue). This is the 36th special issue in Videha's sustained series of living-person visheshanks, which Videha's editor Gajendra Thakur initiated in 2015 with the declared purpose of documenting and critically appreciating individuals who are actively shaping Mithila's cultural, literary, and ecological landscape. The present report draws primarily on the content of that issue, supplemented by major web sources.

The Mithila region — covering the districts of Darbhanga, Madhubani, Sitamarhi, Samastipur, Supaul and others in northern Bihar — has historically been defined by an exceptional density of ponds and water bodies, encapsulated in the traditional proverb: 'Pag-pag pokhar, macch-makhan' (every step a pond, fish and makhana). The disappearance of these ponds in recent decades is both an ecological crisis and a cultural loss that Narayanji Chaudhary has fought to halt, document, and reverse.

# 2. Biographical Profile

| | |
|---|---|
| **Full Name** | Narayan Ji Chaudhary (नारायणजी चौधरी) |
| **Date of Birth** | 30 August 1959 |
| **Native Village** | Isahpur, Pandaul (Pandaul Police Station), |

| | |
|---|---|
| | Madhubani District, Bihar |
| **Education** | B.Com (Honours) |
| **Occupation / Vocation** | Social Work (Saamaajik Kaaj) |
| **Organisation** | Mithila Gram Vikas Parishad (Mithila Village Development Council) |
| **Campaign / Abhiyan** | Talab Bachao Abhiyan (Save Ponds Campaign); later expanded to Jalashay Bachao Abhiyan (Save Water Bodies Campaign) |
| **Father** | Late Pt. Vaidyanath Chaudhary |
| **Mother** | Panchmukhi Devi |
| **Grandfather** | Late Jeewach Chaudhary |
| **Current Spouse** | Kalita Chaudhary |
| **First Wife (deceased)** | Late Indu Chaudhary |
| **Children** | Aayu Chaudhary, Rahul Chaudhary, Aashu Chaudhary |
| **Brothers** | Raman Ji Chaudhary, Gopal Ji Chaudhary, Kanhaiya Chaudhary |

## 2.1 Early Career and Formative Experience

Narayanji's biographical arc is one of return and recommitment. Before founding his water conservation movement, he spent formative years working in tribal welfare in *Jhabua* and *Bastar* districts of Madhya Pradesh (1984–1990), gaining experience in grassroots development work with Adivasi communities — a period that shaped his understanding of how ecological resources and community welfare are inseparable. After returning to Bihar in 1991, he established the Mithila Gram Vikas Parishad and engaged in social work in the Mithila region.

The moment that catalysed his pond conservation work came around 2002–2005 when handpumps near his office in Darbhanga began to run dry. Investigating the cause, he traced the groundwater depletion to the rapid disappearance of ponds that had historically recharged the aquifer. He also recalled witnessing a similar water supply crisis in the Munirka locality of Delhi around 1982–83, and resolved to act. He travelled to Rajasthan to meet Rajendra Singh ('Jalpurush'), the renowned water conservationist, learning water harvesting techniques before launching a survey of 24 ponds in Darbhanga — including the Neem Pokhar and Man Pokhar — and submitting a memorandum to the administration. This received no response, but it marked the formal beginning of what would become the Talab Bachao Abhiyan.

## 3. The Talab Bachao Abhiyan: Origins, Methods, and Scope

**Talab Bachao Abhiyan (TBA)** — Save Ponds Campaign — was launched by Narayanji Chaudhary through the Mithila Gram Vikas Parishad as an organised civil society movement to resist the systematic encroachment, filling, and destruction of ponds in Darbhanga and the wider Mithilanchal region of northern Bihar. The campaign has expanded over time into the broader **Jalashay Bachao Abhiyan** (Save Water Bodies Campaign), encompassing rivers, wetlands, and other water bodies locally known as *chaur*.

### 3.1 Methods of Intervention

Narayanji Chaudhary and the TBA have operated across multiple registers simultaneously:

**Street and community mobilisation:** The TBA has organised numerous dharnas (sit-in protests), signature campaigns, poster and photo exhibitions during popular festivals such as Durga Puja and Chhath Puja, protest marches, jan sabhas (public meetings), and door-to-door awareness outreach. Over 50 villages have been covered in awareness campaigns. Student groups, political party workers, doctors, engineers, scientists and university faculty have all been drawn into the movement.

**Legal and quasi-legal action:** Chaudhary filed cases before the National Green Tribunal (NGT) against encroachment on three heritage ponds — Harahi, Dighi, and Ganga Sagar — in Darbhanga, which are estimated to be

approximately 600–900 years old. The NGT issued orders to ban illegal construction around them and appointed an inspection committee. When Darbhanga Railway Station was found to be continuously discharging sewage into the Harahi and Dighi ponds, Chaudhary filed a complaint with the NGT that resulted in the Bihar State Pollution Control Board (BSPCB) imposing a fine of Rs 1.61 crore on the Railway Station in early 2025. He also challenged the Kosi Mahasetu (dam/embankment) before the Supreme Court and then the High Court, contending that the structure was dangerously undersized — a case that achieved partial results.

**Documentation and evidence building:** Chaudhary has systematically compiled evidence of encroachment, including drone photographs, survey data, government records, and legal documents, working with collaborators including the late Anidya Banerjee (documentation support) and advocate Kamlesh Kumar Mishra (Supreme Court lawyer, legal support). The TBA was also involved in the listing of natural heritage sites in Darbhanga and Madhubani districts through the INTACH (Indian National Trust for Art and Cultural Heritage) Darbhanga Chapter, established in 2016.

**Institutional partnerships:** Chaudhary has worked with the Maithili Sahitya Sansthan (Patna), the Maharajadhiraj Laxmishwar Singh Sangrahalaya (Darbhanga), INTACH, and individual scientists and academics including the late Padma Shri Dr Manas Bihari Verma (retired DRDO scientist and associate of former President A.P.J. Abdul Kalam), Prof Vidyanath Jha, IAS officer Gajanan Mishra, and river specialist Dinesh Kumar Mishra.

## 3.2 Key Achievements

The following achievements are documented across the primary and secondary sources consulted for this report:

**NGT order and Rs 1.61 crore fine (2022–2025):** The NGT ordered the removal of encroachments around Harahi, Dighi, and Ganga Sagar ponds. Following an BSPCB inquiry triggered by an NGT order, the Darbhanga Railway Station was fined Rs 1.61 crore for polluting Harahi and Dighi ponds with sewage discharge (February 2025). This was described in the Videha Visheshank as one of the most significant court-driven environmental compensation orders ever issued in Bihar for pond protection.

**University pond and Vice-Chancellor penalised:** When the administration of Lalit Narayan Mithila University (LNMU) undertook a "beautification" project that damaged the Kameshwar Nagar campus pond, Chaudhary filed a case

before the NGT. The court ordered the pond enclosure to be restored and the Vice-Chancellor was penalised.

**Makhnaahi and other community successes:** In 2023, a 10-decimal pond in Makhnaahi was saved from encroachment after local communities, energised by TBA awareness campaigns, confronted the land mafia. In Bajitpur (Manigachi), a 15-acre pond (Suryahi Pokhar) was saved in 2024 when residents filed a police complaint after encroachment began.

**Chief Minister's announcement:** Following sustained pressure from TBA and allied groups, the Bihar Chief Minister announced Rs 75 crore for the integration and beautification of the Harahi, Dighi, and Ganga Sagar ponds. Whether these funds will be properly utilised remains a subject of watchful concern for the movement.

**Recognition and honours:** In October 2024, TBA and Chaudhary were formally honoured at Maharaja Laxmishwar Singh Memorial College, Darbhanga, in a programme co-organised by the College and INTACH Darbhanga Chapter. In January 2025, he was honoured by the Maithili Sahitya Sansthan, Patna, on the occasion of Maithili Day.

## 4. The Ecological Crisis: Ponds of Mithila in Historical Perspective

Understanding Chaudhary's campaign requires grasping the severity of the ecological transformation underway in Mithila. The historical and statistical picture assembled from Videha 419 and corroborated by external sources is stark:

**1964:** The Darbhanga District Gazetteer recorded over 300 ponds in Darbhanga town alone.

**1989:** A research survey by Prof. S.H. Bajmi of Millat College, Darbhanga found 213 ponds remaining — a decline of 87 in 25 years.

**2016:** The Darbhanga Urban Body's official data showed only 84 ponds remaining.

**2024:** Estimates now put the number at less than 100, with many of those encroached, polluted, or barely functional.

**Statewide:** Bihar's government has acknowledged that of the state's 1.99 lakh water bodies, at least 12,027 have been encroached upon by powerful land-mafia–administration nexuses.

The causes of this crisis are interlocking: rapid and poorly regulated urbanisation; a nexus between land mafia, property dealers, and local officials who profit from converting pond land to construction sites; administrative indifference; and a loss of cultural awareness of the ecological and cultural value of ponds. The consequences are equally multi-dimensional: groundwater depletion (Bihar's groundwater table has dropped 10–15 feet since 2005, with 60% attributed to pond loss according to Down to Earth); seasonal waterlogging in formerly well-drained areas; loss of biodiversity (approximately 20% of Mithila's fish species have been lost according to Down to Earth 2024); devastation of the livelihoods of Mallah (fishing) communities and makhana producers; and the erasure of the cultural rituals — Chhath, Durga Puja, community festivals — that were traditionally associated with these water bodies.

*As scholar Pranav Jha writes in Videha 419:* "The encroachment of ponds in Mithila over the last two to two-and-a-half decades has been rapid and systematic. Land mafia has filled ponds with soil and debris, constructing houses, shops and buildings on them. This has spread across virtually every district of Mithila, bringing the region's water wealth into crisis."

## 5. Critical Appreciation: Significance, Strengths, and Limitations

### 5.1 The Significance of the Man and the Movement

Narayanji Chaudhary's significance operates simultaneously at the personal, social, ecological, and civilisational levels.

**As a moral exemplar:** Multiple contributors to the Videha Visheshank — including Dr Shiv Kumar Mishra, Hitanath Jha, Dr Dhankar Thakur, Dr Kailash Kumar Mishra, and Ajit Kumar Jha — independently emphasise what may be the most striking feature of Chaudhary's career: that he acts without political office, financial incentive, or institutional backing. He has faced death threats, physical intimidation, and false FIRs filed against him and his associates by land mafia networks. A collaborator was killed in 2015 while saving the

Betagami pond. Despite all of this, Chaudhary has continued his work with, as several writers describe it, the quality of a *bataahpani* — a productive, almost reckless devotion — a quality he himself humorously acknowledged is a prerequisite for heritage conservation work.

**As a legal innovator:** Chaudhary's decision to use the National Green Tribunal as a strategic tool — filing public-interest-style complaints about specific ponds — represents an important innovation in grassroots environmental activism in Bihar. Rather than relying solely on street protest or media advocacy, he built evidentiary dossiers and engaged the courts. The Rs 1.61 crore fine imposed on the Darbhanga Railway Station is described in the primary sources as likely the first time a railway establishment in Bihar has been financially penalised for damaging a pond ecosystem. The broader NGT jurisprudence on ponds in Darbhanga has set important precedents for the entire Mithilanchal region.

**As a cultural conservator:** Chaudhary frames his work not merely in environmental or legal terms but explicitly in cultural-civilisational terms. Ponds such as Harahi, Dighi, and Ganga Sagar are not just water bodies — they are 600–900-year-old living archives of Mithila's cultural life. They are sites for Chhath Puja, Durga Puja, and other rituals; they sustained the fisheries and makhana cultivation that defined Mithila's agrarian identity; and they embody a sophisticated traditional water management system whose engineering logic — seasonal recharge, flood buffering, microclimate regulation — is now confirmed by modern hydrology. Dr Kailash Kumar Mishra compares Chaudhary's significance to that of Sundarlal Bahuguna (Chipko movement) and Kailash Satyarthi (Bachpan Bachao Andolan): ecological-cultural activists whose work transcends narrow environmentalism to touch the foundations of a civilisation.

**As a catalyst for civic discourse:** Dr Shiv Kumar Mishra's essay in Videha 419 documents how Chaudhary's 2019 seminar at the Maithili Sahitya Sansthan — presided over by Padma Shri Manas Bihari Verma — brought together water specialists, IAS officers, academics, journalists, and civil society representatives in a structured discussion of Mithila's water crisis. The media coverage of that event sparked similar discussions across Mithila-related institutions. The Videha Visheshank itself, by devoting 97 pages to Chaudhary's work, is an act of canonical inscription: it places this socially marginal activist within the official archive of Mithila's intellectual life.

## 5.2 Strengths of the Movement

**Grassroots credibility:** The TBA is not an NGO with external funding or a political front. It emerged organically from the community's experience of water scarcity and has maintained its independence from political parties — a quality that has allowed it to appeal across caste, community, and political lines. The Hindu-Muslim co-ownership visible in the heritage of Mithila's ponds (the Mirza Khan Talab was built by a Muslim community, the Harahi by a Hindu king, but both are used by all communities) is reflected in the movement's composition, which includes Mohammed Tashim Nawab as a leading collaborator.

**Scientific backing:** Unlike many grassroots movements that operate on cultural or emotional grounds alone, TBA has actively sought scientific validation. The involvement of DRDO scientist Manas Bihari Verma, Bihar Water Resources Department official Gajanan Mishra, botanist Sunil Kumar Mishra, and various university faculty members gives the campaign a credibility in scientific and administrative circles that street protests alone cannot provide.

**Adaptive broadening:** The evolution from Talab Bachao Abhiyan (focused on ponds) to Jalashay Bachao Abhiyan (covering all water bodies — rivers, ponds, wetlands/chaur) reflects a learning organisation. The 2018–2019 water crisis in Darbhanga and neighbouring districts demonstrated that individual ponds cannot be saved in isolation from the broader hydrology of the region, and Chaudhary's movement adapted accordingly.

## 5.3 Limitations and Challenges: A Candid Assessment

A critical appreciation demands honest engagement with the movement's limitations alongside its achievements. Several contributors to the Videha Visheshank themselves offer candid assessments:

**Structural power asymmetry:** The land mafia–administration–political nexus that Chaudhary confronts is deeply entrenched. Despite NGT orders, encroachments continue. False FIRs are filed against activists. Chaudhary himself acknowledges to Videha that even after two decades, no person in Darbhanga has been successfully prosecuted for pond encroachment, and that the movement's impact on the ground remains limited despite its success in courts and media. The movement wins orders; the administration fails to implement them.

**Scale and resource constraints:** The TBA is essentially a movement of volunteers with minimal infrastructure. The scale of the pond destruction — across thousands of ponds in multiple districts — vastly exceeds the capacity of a single civil society initiative, however dedicated. Dr Kailash Kumar Mishra, while celebrating Chaudhary's contribution, explicitly calls for replication at every district, sub-district, block, and gram panchayat level, and for social accounting of water body management. Without institutional and state-level systemic change, individual heroism can only partially arrest the crisis.

**Media and public attention:** While TBA has received coverage in national outlets (The Hindu, Mongabay India, Down to Earth, NewsClick, Hindustan Times, IANS, Jagran), the movement has not achieved the national visibility or policy impact of comparable movements (Chipko, Narmada Bachao Andolan, Tarun Bharat Sangh). Ajit Kumar Jha's essay in Videha 419 begins with the striking admission that on first encountering Chaudhary's name in the Visheshank announcement, he assumed it must be a literary figure, because Chaudhary's social renown had not yet penetrated the educated Maithili reading community. This is both a criticism of public awareness and a tribute to Videha's value as a knowledge commons.

**Institutional recognition gap:** Multiple contributors — notably Dr Kailash Kumar Mishra — call explicitly for Narayanji Chaudhary to be awarded the Padma Shri or equivalent national honour, arguing that his decades of selfless work deserve at least the recognition given to Sundarlal Bahuguna. The absence of such recognition is partly a reflection of the marginalisation of ecological activists from Tier-2 cities in India's national awards discourse.

## 6. The Videha Visheshank: Structure, Contributors, and Editorial Significance

Videha Issue 419 (01 June 2025) is a *Visheshank* (special issue) of 97 pages devoted entirely to Narayanji Chaudhary. It is the 36th special issue in Videha's living-person/institution series, initiated in 2015. The editorial framework for these special issues is described by editor Gajendra Thakur in an extended methodological note: Videha's visheshanks aspire to offer five simultaneous registers — the flavour of a magazine special, of a critical monograph, of a research thesis, of a Sahitya Akademi monograph, and (where applicable) of a dual-subject evaluation when both a person and their spouse are writers. Thakur also notes that Videha visheshanks have become a reference point for doctoral

researchers in Maithili studies, as each issue provides a multi-perspectival, densely referenced profile of its subject that would otherwise not exist in the academic literature.

## 6.1 Contributors and Their Perspectives

The Visheshank includes the following substantive contributions:

**Hitanath Jha (Editor's commentary, pp. 1–2):** Provides an overview, situating the Chaudhary Visheshank within Videha's editorial tradition and commending its departure from literary subjects to honour a water conservationist. Jha specifically praises the inclusion of research-quality essays by Dhankar Thakur, Kailash Kumar Mishra, and others.

**Brief biography / परिचय (pp. 30–31):** Factual profile providing key biographical data, career trajectory, and family details, reproduced with photo documentation.

**List of TBA collaborators (pp. 32–34):** Documents over 40 grassroots and intellectual collaborators of the Talab Bachao Abhiyan — from village-level workers to Supreme Court advocates and DRDO scientists — along with a tribute to the late Anidya Banerjee and others who have passed on.

**Randhir Jha, 'Water Rich Mithila then, Water Crisis in Mithila Now!' (pp. 35–44):** An English-language analytical essay placing Mithila's water crisis in historical and hydrological context, detailing the causes of groundwater depletion, the destruction of traditional water management systems, and the emergence of Chaudhary's campaign as a model civil society response. This is the most comprehensive English-language document in the issue.

**Dr Shiv Kumar Mishra, 'Mithilak Dharoharr Abhiyaani Narayan Ji Chaudhary' (pp. 45–52):** A personal essay in Maithili drawing on Mishra's experience as Director of the Maharajadhiraj Laxmishwar Singh Sangrahalaya, Darbhanga. Mishra recounts his collaboration with Chaudhary from 2017 onwards, the events leading to the NGT orders, the Padma Shri Manas Bihari Verma seminar of 2019, and the INTACH citation of 2024. Written with scholarly detachment and personal warmth.

**Pranav Jha, 'Mithila me Pokhark Atikraman aa "Talab Bachao Abhiyan"' (pp. 53–64):** An analytical essay in Maithili that provides the most detailed statistical and historical account of pond loss in Mithila, with specific data on Darbhanga and Madhubani districts, case studies of specific ponds, and documentation of the mafia's operational methodology (nocturnal filling, fake

land registration, enclosure construction). Cites Down to Earth, Mongabay, and government data.

**Hitanath Jha, 'Jal Sanrakshan aa Narayanji Chaudhary' (pp. 65–69):** An essay tracing Chaudhary's personal motivation and the structural causes of Mithila's water crisis, with testimony from retired IAS officer Gajanan Mishra and historian-botanist Prof Vidyanath Jha.

**Dr Dhankar Thakur, 'Pokharr Bachao Abhiyaank Mithila Nayak — Narayan Chaudhary' (pp. 70–71):** A personal tribute in Maithili from a prominent Maithili cultural activist, situating Chaudhary's work in the tradition of Mithila's water stewardship heroes.

**Ajit Kumar Jha, 'Mithilak Sanskritic Dharoharr ke Rakshak: Narayan Chaudhary' (pp. 72–77):** A reflective essay that begins with an honest admission of prior ignorance of Chaudhary's work and proceeds to articulate a powerful argument for why Chaudhary — a non-literary, non-political activist — is precisely the kind of 'real hero' that Mithila needs to celebrate.

**Dr Kailash Kumar Mishra, 'Narayan Chaudhary aa Jalkar Sanrakshan ker Samaajik Sarokaar' (pp. 78–85):** The most intellectually ambitious essay in the issue, weaving together Vedic philosophy (the Prithvi Sukta from the Atharvaveda), anthropology of Kashyap gotra's turtle conservation practices, cultural ecology, and direct analysis of the TBA's methods. Calls explicitly for Padma Shri recognition, national replication of Chaudhary's model, and doctoral research on his work.

**Ashish Anchinhar, 'Pokharrak Vaktavya' (pp. 86–94):** A Maithili poem first written in 2005, presented as a long-delayed personal tribute that was composed even before Anchinhar was aware of Chaudhary's campaign — suggesting the poem as a kind of premonitory voice of the ponds themselves.

**References (pp. 95–97):** 23 references including government documents, NGT orders, media reports, academic surveys, and Facebook links.

## 7. National and Comparative Significance

Down to Earth (India) has cited Narayanji Chaudhary's Talab Bachao Abhiyan in multiple reports on urban wetland conservation as one of the most sustained community-led pond conservation efforts in northern India. Mongabay India's 2020 profile — 'Saving Darbhanga's wetlands from encroachment and apathy' — described TBA as one of the rare cases where local civil society pressure has

succeeded in pushing judicial intervention to protect urban water bodies. India Water Portal has published two profiles of TBA (2014 and 2024). NewsClick carried multiple reports between 2019 and 2024.

Down to Earth's 2021 feature on India's urban wetlands explicitly cited the Mithilanchal campaign as a model for community-led conservation, alongside Shweta Hule's 'Swamini' self-help group's mangrove conservation work in Maharashtra — placing Chaudhary in the national wetland conservation conversation.

The comparison drawn by contributors to the Videha Visheshank — Chaudhary alongside Sundarlal Bahuguna, Rajendra Singh ('Jalpurush'), and Kailash Satyarthi — is not mere rhetorical flourish. Each of these figures worked through the same combination of direct action, legal intervention, coalition building, and non-violent resistance. Chaudhary's contribution is geographically more circumscribed — focused on Darbhanga and Mithilanchal rather than a national-scale movement — but within his region, his impact on public discourse and pond conservation policy has been analogous. He is, as Prof Gajanan Mishra of the Bihar Water Resources Department states in Videha 419: *"among local people, known as a protector of ponds, as he put the issue in public discourse and mobilised people to fight for the conservation of ponds."*

## 8. Conclusion

Narayanji Chaudhary's career embodies a model of citizenship that is rare in any society and especially in contemporary India's civic landscape: sustained, non-institutional, financially unrewarded, physically courageous, and scientifically grounded environmental stewardship. He has worked without political party backing, without major donor funding, without the visibility of a national media platform, and in the face of organised criminal intimidation. He has created a civil society archive of Mithila's disappearing water bodies that now has a presence in the NGT, the BSPCB, the national press, and — through Videha Issue 419 — in the permanent record of Mithila's intellectual culture.

The Videha Visheshank dedicated to him is itself a significant act. By placing a grassroots environmental activist alongside the literary and cultural figures that constitute the normal subject matter of Maithili literary journals, editor Gajendra Thakur has enacted precisely the kind of canon-broadening that characterises Videha's Parallel Literature Movement. The Visheshank demonstrates that the defence of a pond is as much a cultural act as the

composition of a ghazal — that ecology and culture are, in Mithila as everywhere, inseparable.

Several tasks remain. The sustainability of the TBA beyond its founding figure is uncertain; the movement needs institutionalisation and replication. Chaudhary's work lacks the doctoral and policy research attention it deserves. And as Dr Kailash Kumar Mishra's essay argues compellingly, the national awards apparatus has yet to recognise a figure whose work has prevented environmental damage worth orders of magnitude more than any financial calculation can express. In the meantime, the movement continues. As of February 2025 — the month of the most recent sources consulted — TBA members were still being threatened by land mafia groups, still filing complaints with district magistrates and SSPs, and still fighting, in Chaudhary's own characterisation, a *'difficult task'* made necessary by *"the apathy of government and local administration."*

It is that combination of clear-eyed assessment of the odds and undimmed commitment to the work that makes Narayanji Chaudhary not merely an activist, but a model of what civic engagement looks like at its best.

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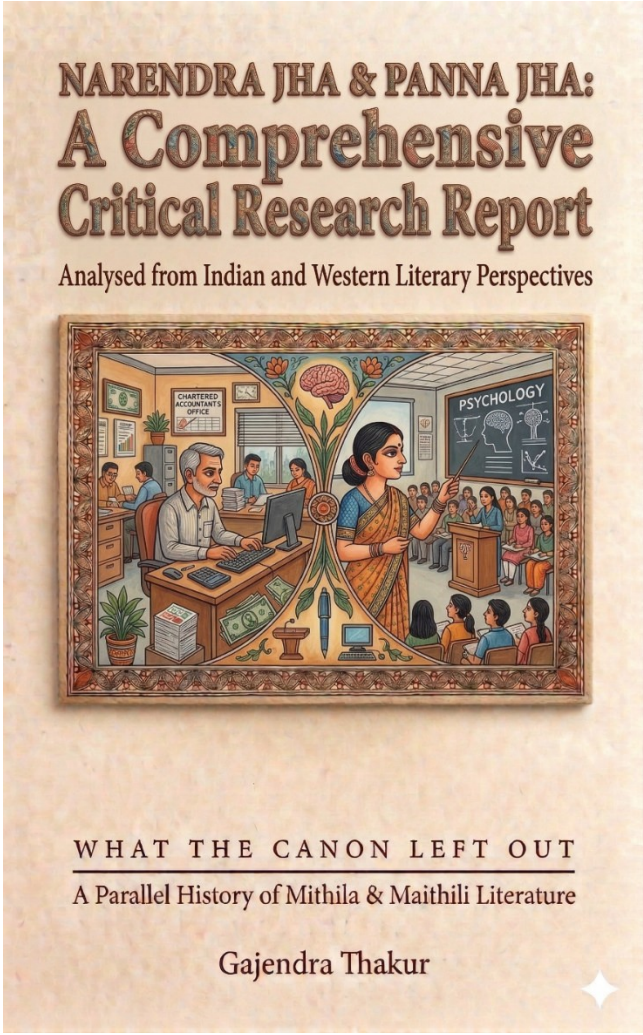
**LESSON 053 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**



# NARENDRA JHA & PANNA JHA

*A Comprehensive Critical Research Report*

*Analysed from Indian and Western Literary Perspectives*

Abstract:

This research report presents a systematic critical analysis of the literary and intellectual work of Narendra Jha (b. 1934) and Panna Jha (b. 1946), two foundational figures in twentieth and twenty-first century Maithili writing. Narendra Jha, a Chartered Accountant from Patna, pioneered the genre of economic and political writing in Maithili — a domain the language had largely ceded to Hindi and English. His eight works, spanning from Mithilak Arthik Vikas (2000) to Mithila Rising (2014) and Chapal Charan Chit Chanchal Bhan (2021), constitute the most sustained body of economic-geographic analysis of the Mithila region available in an Indian regional language. Panna Jha, his wife, a retired Professor of Psychology from Magadh University, produced three major Maithili works — Anubhuti (2009/2010), Anusheelan (2012), and Abhilasha (2021) — that bring psychoanalytic depth, feminist consciousness, and Maithili social critique into the short story and essay forms. Together they represent what Videha editor Gajendra Thakur has called the dampati lekhaka (couple-writers) tradition in Maithili, each enriching the other's intellectual orientation. This report analyses their works through dual critical lenses: Indian literary-philosophical traditions (Navya-Nyaya epistemology, Sahitya Shastra, postcolonial Indian criticism, subaltern studies, feminist literary traditions) and Western theoretical frameworks (Gramscian organic intellectualism, Amartya Sen's capabilities approach, postcolonial theory, ecofeminism, psychoanalytic literary criticism, and narrative theory).

## 1. Biographical Context

### 1.1 Narendra Jha (1934–2024)

Narendra Jha was born on 22 September 1934 (Ananta Chaturdashi, Bhadrapad Shukla), in Tarauni village, Darbhanga district, Bihar — an ancient centre of Sanskrit scholarship. His father, Vidyavachaspati Pandit Upendra Jha, was a

distinguished Sanskrit scholar who received the Rashtrapati Award from the President of India, establishing a hereditary tradition of learning. This hereditary root in the Sanskrit-Maithili intellectual tradition shaped Narendra Jha's lifelong sensibility even as his professional trajectory moved toward modern accountancy.

Jha studied at Darbhanga, completing his B.Com. in 1954. During this period he first associated with Lakshmana Jha (the celebrated Lakhan Jha), participating early in the Mithila-Maithili cultural movement. He relocated to Kolkata in August 1956 to prepare for the Chartered Accountancy examination, qualifying as a Chartered Accountant (C.A.) in January 1966. He practised in Kolkata for nearly a decade, then moved to Delhi before settling permanently in Patna in 1975, where he founded the firm Jha & Associates (406–407, Grand Plaza, Fraser Road, Patna – 800001, Bihar). He married Panna Jha on 3 July 1959, who became a distinguished academic (retired professor of psychology) and a writer in her own right — making them what the Maithili literary world recognises as a *dampati lekhaka* (couple-writers) partnership. Videha Issue 395 (June 2024) was dedicated to him as a living-writer special number — the first systematic critical reckoning with their full body of work. His younger brother is the poet Agnipushpa.

In Kolkata he encountered Suniti Kumar Chatterji and the Mithila Research Institute circle, and remained connected to the leaders of the Mithila-Maithili movement — Dr. Lakshmana Jha, Babu Saheb Choudhury, and Dr. Prabodh Narayan Singh — across cities. He was Chairman of the Patna Branch of the Central India Regional Council of the Institute of Chartered Accountants of India (ICAI), and played a foundational role in establishing the ICAI's Darbhanga branch, which opened in January 2024 — just weeks after the Videha special issue on his work was announced.

A heart surgery in 1997–98 became a decisive biographical turning point. Realising he had not contributed sufficiently to the Mithila-Maithili cause through writing, he began systematic literary and analytical work, also becoming active on Akashvani Patna's Maithili programme Bharati. The editorial note of Videha 395 records poignantly that his wife Panna Jha has since passed away (*svargiya*). He received the Vaidyanath Mishra 'Yatri' Samman in 2019 alongside his wife Panna Jha at a ceremony jointly organised by Akhil Bharatiya Maithili Sahitya Parishad (Darbhanga) and Mithilanchal Vikas Parishad (Laheriasarai, Darbhanga). He was the founding President of Maithili Lekhak Sangh, Patna.

### 1.2 Panna Jha (1946–2024)

Panna Jha (née Choudhary) was born on Ram Navami, April 1946, in Dularpur village, Darbhanga district. Her father was Shri Shubhnarayan Choudhary. She married Narendra Jha on 3 July 1959. She graduated from Bihar University (Muzaffarpur), completed her M.A. from Calcutta University in 1967, and received her Ph.D. from Patna University, both in Psychology. She served as a Professor and Head of the Department of Psychology at J.D. Women's College (Magadh University), Patna, from which she retired in 2008.

Her literary career began in 1965, with contributions to Maithili journals and magazines including Mithila Darshan, Mithila Mihir, Shikha, and Katha Pushpa. She was an active member of Maithili Mahila Sangh, Patna, serving successively as member, secretary, vice-president, president, and adviser, shaping it into one of the most effective Maithili women's organisations. She received three major literary honours: the Shri Janaki Samman (Maithili Mahila Sangh, Patna), the Yatri Samman (Mithilanchal Vikas Parishad, Laheriasarai, Darbhanga), and the Mithila Vibhuti Samman (Akhil Bharatiya Mithila Sangh, New Delhi). She also received the Chetna Samiti Tamrapatra in 2022.

Panna Jha passed away on 15 February 2024 (Saraswati Puja night), aged 78. Her death was described in Videha 395 as the loss of Maithili's foremost woman psychologist-author.

## 2. Complete Bibliography

### 2.1 Works of Narendra Jha

#### *2.1.1 Mithilak Arthik Vikas (2000)*

Title: मिथिलाक आर्थिक विकास [Economic Development of Mithila]. Language: Maithili. Year: 2000. Available at: videha.co.in/pothi.htm . This founding text establishes the intellectual architecture of all his subsequent work, providing a theoretical survey of Mithila's economic underdevelopment across agriculture, industry, infrastructure, and land use, alongside empirical data on the region's deindustrialisation during the post-Independence era.

### *2.1.2 Mithilak Janapadiya Vikas (2005)*

Title: मिथिलाक जनपदीय विकास [Sub-Regional Development of Mithila]. Language: Maithili. Year: 2005. Available at: videha.co.in/pothi.htm. This volume extends the 2000 book by disaggregating development analysis to the sub-regional (janapad) level, attending to micro-geographical economic differentiation within Mithila. Its key innovation is the recognition that 'Mithila' is not an economically homogeneous zone: different districts face distinct agricultural, hydrological, and industrial conditions.

### *2.1.3 Mithila me Jal-Sansadhan O Prabandhan (2006)*

Title: मिथिला मे जल-संसाधन ओ प्रबंधन [Water Resources and Management in Mithila]. Language: Maithili. Year: 2006. Available at: videha.co.in/pothi.htm. This is his most technically specialised volume, addressing the chronic misgovernance of Mithila's rivers — the Kosi, Kamala, Bagmati, Gandak, and others — and the failure of successive embankment and irrigation projects. Jha argues for scientific, locally-informed water management against politically-motivated embankment culture, positioning flood control and drought prevention as complementary rather than competing objectives.

### *2.1.4 Vikas O Arthtantra (2008)*

Title: विकास ओ अर्थतंत्र [Development and Economy]. Language: Maithili. Year: 2008. Available at: videha.co.in/pothi.htm. This volume comprises two major sections: the first analyses the political economy of development — including essays on the need for Mithila statehood, the role of Maithili-serving organisations, the causes of brain drain from Mithila, and an evaluation of Panchayati Raj — while the second contains personal memoirs and tributes to the movement's leaders (Dr. Lakshmana Jha, Babu Saheb Choudhury, Dr. Prabodh Narayan Singh).

### *2.1.5 Paribhraman (2012)*

Title: परिभ्रमण [Wandering / Travel]. Language: Maithili. Year: 2012. Available at: videha.co.in/pothi.htm. A travel memoir that chronicles Jha's journeys across Mithila and beyond. The travelogue genre allows him to weave together personal experience, cultural observation, and economic commentary in a more literary register than his analytical books.

### *2.1.6 Arthtantra O Bhrashtachar (2012)*

Title: अर्थतंत्र ओ भ्रष्टाचार [Economy and Corruption]. Language: Maithili. Year: 2012. Publisher: Aparna Prakashan, Patna. Available at: videha.co.in/pothi.htm. This is his most politically incisive volume. Drawing on empirical data — including references to The Economist's Democracy Index — he analyses corruption as a structural feature of Mithila's political economy rather than an individual moral failing. Key essays include 'Lokapala Nahin Dhokhapal' (critiquing the Lokpal Bill), 'Janvare me Manmohan ki Arthaniiti', and 'Diwaliya Lal Durge me Mamata Banerji'.

### *2.1.7 Smriti (2013)*

Title: स्मृति [Memory]. Language: Maithili. Year: 2013. Available at: videha.co.in/pothi.htm. A memoir collection drawing on personal and movement history, in which Jha situates his own intellectual formation within the broader arc of the Mithila-Maithili movement from the 1950s through the 2000s.

### *2.1.8 Mithila Rising (2014)*

Language: English. Publisher: Sasta Sahitya Mandal, N-77, First Floor, Connaught Circus, New Delhi – 110001. First Edition: 2014. Price: Rs. 250/-. ISBN: 978-81-7309-805-5. Pages: 167. Cover painting by Sunita Jha (Madhubani art). Foreword by Krishna Dutt Paliwal (Secretary, Sasta Sahitya Mandal). Chapters: Preface (p. 9); 1. Introduction (p. 11); 2. People (p. 17); 3. Land (p. 21); 4. Rivers and River Valley Projects (p. 23); 5. Agriculture (p. 43); 6. Industries (p. 54); 7. Development of Infrastructure (p. 117); 8. Revival of Sick Industries (p. 143); 9. Industrial Labour, Trade Union Movement (p. 146); 10. Trade, Including Retail Sector (p. 152); 11. Microfinance and Self Help Group (p. 158); 12. State Hood for Mithila (p. 161); Bibliography (p. 164).

### *2.1.9 Chapal Charan Chit Chanchal Bhan (2021)*

Title: चपल चरन चित चंचल भान [Restless Feet, Wandering Mind, Bright Consciousness]. Language: Maithili. Year: 2021 (written 2009 for Antika journal; first published as part of 'Apna Nazari Me'). An autobiographical prose work, whose title is drawn from a celebrated verse of Maithili's medieval poet Vidyapati, structurally enacting the connection between classical Maithili aesthetics and Jha's own restless, searching life.

## 2.2 Works of Panna Jha

### *2.2.1 Psycho Social Stress and Schizophrenia (2003)*

Language: English. Year: 2003. An academic monograph on schizophrenia and social stress, drawing on her decades of teaching and research in psychology. This work is not available freely online (unavailable at videha.co.in/pothi.htm).

### *2.2.2 Anubhuti (2009 / 2010)*

Title: अनुभूति [Experience / Feeling]. Genre: Short story collection (Maithili). Publisher: Antika Prakashan, Ghaziabad. First Edition: 2009 (some bibliographic records give 2010). Copyright: Sanjiv Kumar Jha. Stories (13): Asaman ke Sarokaar (11–16), Sarokaar (17–20), Pen Friend (21–24), Punaravritti (25–32), Samasyaa Apan Apan (33–36), Dhairy (37–41), Ek Aavashyaktaa Mudaa Atirikt (42–43), Pratishodh (44–47), Peedaa (48–52), Antardvandva (53–57), Kamauaa (58–62), Bataahi (63–68), Sunari (69–72), Kaali Pujan (73–74), Vyathaa Patra (75–79), Niiti Prakaran (80–84), Moolyaankan (85–90), Dharti Chhodanaa Hai (91–92), Anmol Aanand (93–98), Seva Nivritti (99–103), Baur Ghuriye Gel (104–111), Asaaman Ke (Asaman ke). Dedication: To all the characters and persons whose inspiration prompted the stories.

### *2.2.3 Anusheelan (2012)*

Title: अनुशीलन [Practice / Cultivation]. Genre: Essay collection (Maithili). Publisher: Antika Prakashan, C-56/UGF-IV, Shalimar Garden Ext.-II, Ghaziabad-201005 (U.P.). First Edition: 2012. ISBN: 978-93-81923-25-2. Price: Rs. 250.00. Cover: Panna Jha. Essays (17): Sahitya aa Sahitya-Drishti (VII–10); Sahitya Kiyak Likhail Jay (11–15); Prachin Bharatiya Sanskriti me Nari (16–22); Samajak Sashaktikaran me Maithil Mahilak Yogdan (23–28); Beti: Srijan aa Sangharshak Roop (29–32); Aadhunik Maithili Kathaa me Nari (33–47); Maithili-Natak evam Kalkattaak Avadan (48–58); Fashion: Ek Aavashyaktaa (59–62); Dhooaa-Putaak Fhuus Baajab (63–65); Kamkaaji Mahilaa: Suvidha-Asuvidha (66–69); Vidyaarthi aa Anushasan-Nahintaa (70–77); Hinataak Bhavnaa evam Takar Nidaan (78–82); Aatmahatya: Maansik Vikriti (83–91); Baal Aparaadh: Samajik Abhishaap (92–99); Bhrashtachar: Kaaran aa Nidaan (100–105); Bhoot-Pretak Astitva: Mano-Samajik Vishleshan (106–110); Nari-Lekhanak Kathaa-Dishaa (111–140). Foreword by Mohan Bhardwaj.

### *2.2.4 Abhilasha (2021)*

Title: अभिलाषा [Desire / Aspiration]. Genre: Short story collection (Maithili). Publisher: Antika Prakashan Pvt. Ltd., C-56/UGF-IV, Shalimar Garden Ext.-II, Ghaziabad-201005 (U.P.). First Edition (Sajild): 2021. ISBN: 978-93-88799-96-6. Price: Rs. 230.00. Cover: Vinay Ambar. Prefaces by Bhimnaath Jha (Darbhanga) and Gaurinath (Sahodi Divas, 23 March 2021). The collection features stories of women navigating patriarchal constraints with aspiration and agency; the opening story ‘Gayatri, Shipra, Shruti aa Manjit San Bucchhiya Sabhak Man Ke Bujhbaak Aagraha’ sets the tone for psychological realism with social critique.

## 3. Narendra Jha: Analytical Study

### 3.1 The Pioneer of Economic Writing in Maithili

Narendra Jha occupies a historically unique position in Maithili literature: he is virtually the only person to have produced a sustained, multi-volume body of non-literary, social-scientific writing in the language across a span of twenty-two years. This is not merely a biographical curiosity — it reflects a structural condition of Maithili writing. As Ashish Anchinhar observes in Videha 395, Maithili literature is ‘malnourished’ (kuposit) — overfed on fiction, poetry, and personal memoir while deficient in the analytical writing that any full-function language needs: economic analysis, legal commentary, scientific exposition, policy critique. Narendra Jha, arriving at systematic writing only after his heart surgery at age 63, is the ‘indispensable nutritive element’ for this malnutrition — but also a sign of how fragile this tradition remains.

The closest predecessor available in English is the collective work of S.K. Jha and B.N. Jha, The Economic Heritage of Mithila, and in Maithili the later Arthik Tantra aa Rajniiti by Madhukant Jha. But neither matches Jha’s sustained empirical approach across five dedicated volumes. The Maithili literary establishment, for its part, rarely accorded him the recognition it gave to poets and novelists — despite the fact that his books served as primary reference for anyone attempting to understand Mithila’s economic geography.

## 3.2 Thematic Architecture Across the Economic Books

### *3.2.1 Land, Geology, and Agricultural Decline*

Jha's treatment of Mithila's geography is one of the most careful available in any regional language. In Mithila Rising (Chapter 3, 'Land'), he describes the region as one of the most recently formed geological strata on earth — half a million years old, formed by Himalayan alluvial deposits — making it inherently fertile but also prone to waterlogging and instability. The sub-regional differentiation in Mithilak Janapadiya Vikas (2005) shows that the northern part of Mithila (bordering Nepal) has entirely different agro-economic conditions from the southern portions: the northern zone is flood-prone and heavily dependent on subsistence farming, while parts of the southern zone face drought-like conditions in lean seasons.

The 2014 book's Chapter 5 ('Agriculture') documents the structural decline: 65 per cent of Mithila's population depends on agriculture, yet the agricultural sector is perpetually undercapitalised. He tracks the historical shift from peasant-farmers (kashtkaar) to agricultural labourers, the breakdown of cooperative agriculture, and the absence of agro-processing industries for makhana (foxnut), lichi, mango, jute, and sugarcane — all crops for which Mithila has natural advantages but which reach markets unprocessed, with value captured elsewhere.

### *3.2.2 Rivers: The Core Structural Problem*

The 2006 water resources volume is Jha's most technically demanding contribution. His central argument is that the embankment-culture imposed by successive Bihar and central governments — driven by short-term political calculation rather than hydrological science — has simultaneously made flooding worse and prevented the harnessing of river water for irrigation. Rivers like the Kosi, Kamala, Bagmati, and Gandak, whose courses are controlled by Nepal in their upper reaches, cannot be dammed without international agreement with the Nepalese government, yet this fact is routinely ignored in project planning.

In Arthtantra O Bhrashtachar (2012) he revisits this with data: '76 per cent of Mithila's cultivable land is affected by flooding. The remaining Bihar has 68 per cent land affected by flood and drought.' The Himalayan river interlinking project (10 link channels, of which 5 relate to Mithila) is proposed as the long-term solution. The Kosi High Dam project — a long-stalled proposal whose

planning has been repeatedly frustrated by Indo-Nepal boundary complications — is a recurring reference point in his analysis.

### *3.2.3 Industries and Infrastructure*

Chapter 6 of Mithila Rising (‘Industries’, pp. 54–116 — by far the longest chapter at 63 pages) is the most empirically dense section of his English work. It documents the systematic deindustrialisation of Mithila across sugar (once a major industry with mills at Motipur, Lohat, Sakri, Sugauli), jute, textiles, paper, and agro-processing. He traces the causes to inadequate power supply, poor road connectivity, and a political climate in which industrial investment consistently bypassed Mithila in favour of Patna and the Gangetic plains further west. Chapter 8 (‘Revival of Sick Industries’) and Chapter 9 (‘Industrial Labour, Trade Union Movement’) complete this industrial analysis.

### *3.2.4 Corruption as Structural Underdevelopment*

Arthtantra O Bhrashtachar (2012) is his most politically direct work. Here Jha moves from empirical documentation to structural critique: corruption, he argues, is not an accidental pathology but the operational mechanism by which Mithila’s resources are systematically transferred to other regions and constituencies. The book’s opening section cites The Economist’s Democracy Index, classifying India as a ‘flawed democracy’ on five parameters: electoral process, civil rights, governance efficiency, political participation, and political culture. This international analytical scaffolding is unusual and sophisticated for Maithili writing. Essays on the Lokpal Bill, RTI, the Union Budget, and price inflation position Mithila’s developmental failures within the larger context of national political economy.

### *3.2.5 The Statehood Argument*

The most politically resonant thread across all of Jha’s work is the argument for a separate state of Mithila. In Vikas O Arthtantra (2008), the opening essay ‘Sukh-Samriddhik Lel Apan Rajya’ (A State of Our Own for Prosperity) provides the normative case. In Mithila Rising (Chapter 12, ‘State Hood for Mithila’, pp. 161–163), he makes the argument in English for national and international readers: separation from Bihar and constitution of Mithila as a state under the Indian Union is, he argues, the only solution to the pressing problems of food, health, housing, education, and communication. Only with statehood can people undertake systematic river management and agricultural improvement. The Foreword by Krishna Dutt Paliwal of Sasta Sahitya Mandal

echoes this: Mithila has been sidelined and marginalised despite immense natural resources, and needs special attention and care.

### 3.3 Style and Method

Jha's analytical prose in Maithili is characterised by directness, data-density, and a refusal of literary ornamentation. He consistently refuses to call himself a 'lekhak' (literary author) — a refusal that Ramesh (in his Videha 395 essay) reads both as modesty and as an inadvertent symptom of the Maithili literary establishment's failure to recognise non-literary writing as real writing. His ideological perspective is broadly socialist: he consistently supports planned development, equitable distribution of public resources, and land reform. His rhetoric, especially in the corruption volume, is directly political, naming parties and leaders without diplomatic circumlocution.

A critical weakness identified by Dr. Dhanakara Thakur and Madhukant Jha is that his books are primarily documentary rather than prescriptive — they assemble data impressively but do not always provide adequate solutions or policy frameworks. Thakur's sharper critique targets Jha's relative silence on the Darbhanga Raj (zamindari) as a root cause of Mithila's agrarian impoverishment: how can one diagnose Mithila's poverty without confronting the history of the Raj that extracted peasant surplus, drove farmers into debt-bondage during famines, and transferred wealth to palaces in Calcutta, Patna, Kashi, and Allahabad? Ramesh also notes the problematic use of 'Mithilanchal' (which implies geographic fragmentation of the Mithila region) alongside statehood advocacy.

## 4. Mithila Rising (2014) & VIDEHA ISSUE 395; A Close Reading

Mithila Rising is Jha's only English-language book and his most ambitious single volume, intended to bring the case for Mithila's development and statehood to a national and international readership. Its Madhubani-painted cover (by Sunita Jha) — featuring an ancient tree sheltering a cow, both iconic Mithila motifs — signals the integration of cultural identity with the political-economic argument.

## 4.1 Preface: The Tone of Wounded Dignity

The Preface opens with a statement of civilisational pride combined with contemporary humiliation: ‘Maithils were a great people once… We are backward today – poor, ignorant and weak, an object of pity for rapidly advancing nations.’ This rhetorical combination — ancient glory and modern degradation — structures the entire book. It is the preface of a person writing from within an identity that has been systematically diminished, insisting on its own dignity.

The Preface also states the book’s evidence base: land, people, rivers and river valley projects, agriculture and land reforms, industries (traditional and large-scale), service sector, agro-based industry, infrastructure development (power, roads, railways, waterways, airports), revival of sick industries, industrial labour, trade, microfinance and self-help groups. The claim is comprehensive: Mithila’s potential wealth is vast; it is going to waste through political negligence.

## 4.2 Introduction: History as Argument

The Introduction traces the political history of Mithila from the medieval period through colonial rule. The analysis of the Gorkha presence in the tarai — the strip of land between the hills and the Gangetic plains that was ceded to the Gorkhas by the British in December 1816 at Sugauli — is developed as an argument: Mithila’s rivers originate in Nepal, but the tarai through which they flow is controlled by Gorkha-origin interests, making dam construction and river management impossible without Nepal’s cooperation. This is not merely historical scholarship but a demonstration that Mithila’s economic problems have geopolitical roots that require geopolitical solutions (ultimately, statehood that allows Mithila to negotiate on its own terms with Nepal).

The intellectual genealogy is also traced: Mithila lost political sovereignty in the 14th century but retained intellectual supremacy over northern India through Navya-Nyaya, Nibandha literature, juridical literature, drama, and lyric poetry. The comparison with Athens (which was politically subjugated by Rome but supplied Rome with its intellectual nourishment) is an explicit classical parallel that reframes Maithil identity from victimhood to civilisational contribution.

## 4.3 Agricultural and Industrial Chapters: Empirical Core

Chapters 4–6 (Rivers, Agriculture, Industries) constitute the empirical heart of the book. The river chapter presents detailed project histories of the Kosi High Dam, the Gandak Project, the Saptakoshi Dam, and the 10-link Himalayan River Interlinking proposal. The agriculture chapter documents crop statistics, land holding patterns, irrigation coverage, and the collapse of food security. The industries chapter — the longest at 63 pages — is a detailed inventory of industrial decline: the sugar belt, jute mills, paper mills, textiles, and the complete absence of agro-processing infrastructure for Mithila's distinctive agricultural products.

## 4.4 Statehood Chapter: The Political Climax

Chapter 12 ('State Hood for Mithila', pp. 161–163) is brief but decisive. Jha writes: separation from the heterogeneous and unwieldy State of Bihar and its constitution into a state under the Indian Union is the only solution to Mithila's pressing problems of food, health, housing, education, and communication. Only then can people take up the work of river management and agricultural improvement. The argument is not cultural or ethnic — it is developmental. Statehood is presented as a prerequisite for the administrative capacity to implement the economic solutions documented in the preceding eleven chapters.

## 4,5.VIDEHA 395 CLOSE READING:

## LITERARY AND INTELLECTUAL CHARACTER

### 1. The Non-Literary Writer in a Literary Language

The most fundamental critical point about Narendra Jha — and Videha Issue 395 insists on this repeatedly across its seventeen essays — is that he represents a rare and endangered species: **the non-literary writer in Maithili**. Maithili has an ancient tradition of poetry (Vidyapati, Govindadas) and modern prose fiction, but its non-literary, knowledge-based, socio-economic writing has been chronically underdeveloped. Jha filled this gap almost single-handedly in the domain of political economy.

Ashish Anchinhar's essay "Kuposit Maithili Bhasha-Sahitya Lel Ektaa Anivary Poushtik Tatva" (An Indispensable Nutritive Element for Malnourished Maithili Literature) deploys a medical metaphor: Maithili's literary body has become obese with *katha-kavita-sansmaran* (fiction-poetry-memoir), while the

deficiency of analytical writing on economics, science, law, politics, and technology makes the language malnourished. In this context, Narendra Jha is the *poushtik tatva* — the nutritive element — that the language badly needs.

The Patna-based writer Ramesh's essay makes this sharper: he insists that the so-called non-literary writer (*gair-sahityik lekhak*) is often the *real* writer — more industrious, more data-dependent, more consequential than the literary writer who produces through "natural creative gift." Jha himself consistently refused the title of "writer" (*lekhak*) in Maithili literary circles — an irony that Ramesh dwells on painfully, noting that the Maithili literary establishment never accorded Jha the recognition it gave to poets and novelists, despite the fact that Jha's books served as primary source material for anyone wishing to understand Mithila's economic geography.

**2. The Economist-Activist Duality**

What distinguishes Jha from an academic economist is his *activist* orientation. He is not primarily interested in theory for its own sake but in the concrete, ameliorative change of Mithila's condition. His ideological perspective, as Ramesh characterises it, is broadly **socialist** (*samajwadi*): he consistently takes the side of planned development over anarchic growth, public welfare over private accumulation, and equitable distribution of water and land resources.

His five Maithili books on Mithila's economy form a coherent intellectual project. *Mithilak Arthik Vikas* (2000) establishes the theoretical framework for understanding Mithila's underdevelopment — detailing the many dimensions of its agricultural and industrial decay alongside the theoretical possibilities for revival. *Mithilak Janapadiya Vikas* (2005) examines development at the sub-regional level, attending to the distinctive economic micro-geographies of different *janapad* (localities) within Mithila. *Mithila me Jal Sansadhan* (2006) takes on one of the most pressing structural problems of the region: the chronic mis-management of rivers, embankments, and irrigation that simultaneously causes floods and droughts. *Vikas O Arthtantra* (2008) examines the political economy of development and includes political profiles of Mithila's development leaders (Dr. Lakshmana Jha, Babu Saheb Choudhury, Dr. Prabodh Narayan Singh). *Arthtantra O Bhrashtachar* (2012) — arguably his most widely cited work — analyses corruption as structural rather than accidental, arguing that it systematically undoes any developmental possibility in the region.

**3. *Mithila Rising* (2014) — His English Manifesto**

This 167-page English work, published by Sasta Sahitya Mandal, is Jha's most accessible intervention for a national and global audience. Its structure — moving from people, land, rivers, river valley projects, agriculture, industry, transport, communication, to a political chapter on statehood — constitutes a comprehensive empirical survey and argument. The climactic argument, as quoted by Shailendra Mishra in Videha 395, states plainly that separation from Bihar and the creation of an independent state of Mithila within the Indian Union is the only solution to the region's pressing problems of food, health, housing, education, and communication. He adds that only then can the people begin the urgent work of river management and agricultural improvement.

The book is empirically solid, drawing on data from multiple sources. It traces Mithila's historical glories and empirically documents the systematic withering of industry and agriculture, attributing this not to geographical fatalism but to political design — what several Videha contributors call a *shadyantra* (conspiracy) to keep Mithila economically subjugated so it cannot aspire to separate statehood.

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## IV. CRITICAL RECEPTION IN VIDEHA 395

### Appreciative Perspectives

**Kalpana Jha** analyses Panna Jha's essay collection *Anushilan* and calls it a work requiring sustained critical study (*Anushilan ka Anushilan Avashyak*). While her essay is primarily on Panna Jha, it implicitly situates the couple's intellectual partnership.

**Munni Kamat** reads Jha as the well-wisher of Mithila-Maithil's all-round development (*chahuvikas ka shubhachintaka*).

**Ajit Kumar Jha** directly calls him *Mithilak Arthashastri* — Mithila's Economist — a title none before him has been given.

**Shailendra Mishra** bases his analysis on two books — *Mithila Rising* and *Arthtantra O Bhrashtachar* — and concludes that Jha's breadth of vision encompasses everything from district-level industry to national political analysis. He praises Jha's capacity for forthright, unadorned prose that attracts readers through its directness.

**Dr. Kailash Kumar Mishra** focuses on *Arthtantra O Bhrashtachar* and values especially the democratic-index citation from *The Economist* magazine (rating India as a "flawed democracy" on five parameters: electoral process, civic rights, governance efficiency, political participation, and political culture). He

sees this international empirical scaffolding as a mark of sophistication unusual in Maithili writing.

**Pranav Jha** summarises Jha's triple identity: CA (professional credibility), Maithil economic-social writer (intellectual contribution), and Mithila campaigner (activist).

**Madhukant Jha** celebrates Jha's books as *aitihashik dastaweez* (historical documents) that gather micro-level data on Mithila's land, water, roads, irrigation, electricity, sugar industry, and agricultural produce — data that future researchers and policymakers will depend on.

**Critical Perspectives**

Not all the essays in Videha 395 are uncritical. The journal is explicit in its editorial philosophy: unlike mainstream *abhiandan granth* (felicitation volumes) that suppress critique, Videha's special issues invite honest assessment.

**Dr. Dhanakara Thakur**'s essay carries a title that says it all: *"Mithilak Arthik Paksha Rakhnihar Kintu Aitihashik Vibhram Utpanna Kenihar Lekhak"* — "A Writer Who Champions Mithila's Economic Cause But Creates Historical Confusion." Thakur's criticism focuses on Jha's historiographical errors, particularly regarding the Darbhanga Raj (zamindari) — arguing that Jha does not adequately examine the feudal exploitation of the Darbhanga Maharaja's estate as a root cause of Mithila's economic underdevelopment. How can one diagnose Mithila's poverty without confronting the history of the Raj that extracted wealth, provided lands to 1962 war donations (13 *man* of gold to the government), built palaces in Calcutta-Patna-Kashi-Allahabad from peasant surplus, and drove farmers off their land during famines and floods?

**Madhukant Jha**, while overall appreciative, similarly notes that Jha's books are primarily documentary (data compilation from government and non-government sources) rather than prescriptive, and that they do not sufficiently address the current situation — its solutions and challenges — though the historical data they provide is invaluable.

**Ramesh** raises an important ideological critique: Jha repeatedly uses the term *Mithilanchal* — a divisive geographic term that implicitly fragments Mithila into sub-zones (alongside *Kosi-kanchal, Kamalanchal, Simanchal*) — which gives unwarranted legitimacy to the geographic fragmentation of Mithila. This is, Ramesh suggests, inconsistent with Jha's own Mithila-state advocacy.

**Ashish Anchinhar**'s essay is the most structurally audacious: it places Jha as a *necessary but insufficient* agent of change. Jha's economic writing in Maithili was exemplary but not enough to establish a *leek* (tradition) or ensure a *bhavishya* (future) for economic writing in the language. The fault lies not with Jha but with the Maithili literary establishment that hoards platforms — stage, garland, microphone, award — for fiction-poetry-memoir writers, while those who write in technical disciplines are either ignored or forced to adopt literary genres to gain recognition. The essay ends with a systemic call: IIT professors should write engineering books in Maithili; doctors should write on health; administrators on governance; environmentalists on ecology. Jha's example needs to be a founding model, not an anomaly.

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## V. POSITION IN MAITHILI LITERARY HISTORY

Videha Issue 395 situates Jha within its core intellectual project — the *Samanantar Parampara* (Parallel Tradition) — which champions democratic, non-canonical, knowledge-productive writing over the mainstream Sahitya Akademi canon. Within this framework, Jha is positioned as a figure who demonstrated that Maithili could carry the weight of economic analysis, empirical social commentary, and political argument — a domain the language had, for historical reasons, almost entirely ceded to Hindi and English.

The editorial note by Gajendra Thakur (the *sampAdakIya*) opens with a Vidyapati verse (*Chapal Charan Chit Chanchal Bhan* — also the title of Jha's autobiographical text), and frames Jha as a writer whose life's work constitutes the same kind of restless, vital engagement with the world that Vidyapati's verse celebrates. This is a deliberate genealogical claim: Jha is placed in the lineage of Maithili's classical intellectual energy, recast for the modern economic domain.

The *Vaidyanath Mishra 'Yatri' Samman* (the award named after Nagarjuna, the great Maithili poet) was given to Narendra and Panna Jha at a dignified ceremony in 2019, as recounted in Ramesh's essay — a recognition of their joint contribution that the larger Maithili establishment had consistently failed to provide.

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## VI. SYNTHESIS: STRENGTHS AND LIMITATIONS

**Strengths:**

- Pioneer of economic writing in Maithili, filling a near-total vacuum

- Combines professional expertise (CA, five decades of practice) with deep regional knowledge
- Data-rich, field-informed analysis (multiple ground-level surveys)
- Consistent ideological clarity: pro-planned development, anti-corruption, pro-Mithila statehood
- Bilingual reach: Maithili books for the home community, English *Mithila Rising* for national/global advocacy
- Available freely on Videha pothi.htm — making his work accessible to future researchers
- An activist dimension: connected to Mithila movement leaders across Darbhanga, Kolkata, Patna

**Limitations:**

- Historical analysis is sometimes uncritical of feudal-era institutions (Darbhanga Raj)
- Books are primarily documentary (data assemblage) rather than prescriptive policy analysis with solutions
- Some articles remain sketchy and would benefit from greater depth
- Uses the term *Mithilanchal* (which implies geographical fragmentation) inconsistently with his own statehood argument
- The tradition he initiated in Maithili economic writing has not been continued or extended by others — pointing to a systemic failure of the Maithili literary ecosystem to nurture non-literary writing

## VII. CONCLUSION

Narendra Jha (b. 1934, Tarauni, Darbhanga) is at once a professional Chartered Accountant and a public intellectual whose five decades of writing on Mithila's political economy constitute the single most sustained body of economic analysis available in the Maithili language. His work encompasses land use, water management, agricultural infrastructure, flood governance, corruption, electoral politics, and the case for Mithila statehood. His English book *Mithila Rising* (2014) brings this argument to a national and international readership.

Videha Issue 395 is the first systematic critical reckoning with his work. Its seventeen essays, taken together, establish him not merely as a regional specialist but as a figure of structural importance to any future effort to develop

Maithili as a full-function knowledge language — one capable of hosting discourse in economics, law, science, and governance alongside its already rich literary tradition. The central message of the special issue, to use Ashish Anchinhar's metaphor, is that Jha has been an indispensable nutritive element for a malnourished literary ecosystem — and that Maithili literature's own institutional inertia has both needed him and failed to nourish the tradition he tried to begin.

# 5. Panna Jha: Analytical Study

## 5.1 The Psychologist-Author: A Distinctive Voice

Panna Jha’s writing occupies a distinctive niche in Maithili literature: she is simultaneously a trained academic psychologist (Ph.D., Patna University), a practising educator (Head of Department, Magadh University), a feminist social activist, and a creative writer in both the short story and essay traditions. This combination — psychological expertise, feminist consciousness, social engagement, and literary craft — produces a voice that is unlike any other in Maithili women’s writing.

As Dr. Bhimnaath Jha observes in his preface to Abhilasha, the hallmark of Panna Jha’s fiction is balance (santulan): every event, every utterance is contextually grounded, not improbable or exaggerated. The psychological realism she brings — the result of her clinical and educational engagement with the Maithili social world — prevents her stories from slipping into either sentimentality or polemic, the two besetting faults of much Maithili women’s writing.

## 5.2 Anubhuti (2009/2010): Short Story Collection

### *5.2.1 Structure and Scope*

Anubhuti (Experience / Feeling) is Panna Jha’s first Maithili short story collection, published by Antika Prakashan, Ghaziabad, in 2009 (some copies carry a 2010 date). The collection was written over decades — literary activity she traces to 1965 — but assembled only after her retirement in 2008. The author’s own preface (‘Du Aakhar’) states that each story grew from a life-event that moved her: the impulse to render that event in narrative came from the intersection of emotional response and analytical observation. The title

Anubhuti, she explains, reflects the fact that each story's character gave her life's opportunity, and the event involved moved her heart.

### *5.2.2 Thematic Analysis*

The stories cluster around several recurring themes. The first is the psychology of illness and institutional care: the opening story 'Asaman ke Sarokaar' is set in the waiting room of a psychiatric facility (Luminary Park Mental Hospital), where a consultant physician witnesses the strange encounter between two patients and reflects on the nature of mental illness, social rejection, and human dignity. The clinical setting allows Panna Jha to draw on her academic expertise while constructing a narrative about social marginalisation.

The second major theme is women's struggle against patriarchal constraint. Stories like 'Pratishodh' (Revenge), 'Peedaa' (Pain), and 'Antardvandva' (Internal Conflict) follow women who resist, subvert, or ultimately transcend the social codes that confine them. Hitnaath Jha, reviewing the collection in Videha 395, notes: 'Maithil women's struggle as found here — breaking the conventional Maithili rigidity of the last forty-fifty years, breaking false conventions of relationships, finding one's own identity — is the founding stone of women's self-reliance.'

The third theme is inter-generational transmission of trauma. 'Punaravritti' (Repetition) is the most structurally ambitious story in the collection: a daughter who discovers she is re-enacting her father's pattern of behaviour across generations, but who consciously decides to break the cycle while respecting its emotional reality ('I am not doing anything new — people say one's environment and genetics have influence. Perhaps that is why I am re-enacting your generational pattern. In future I will keep your feelings and honour in mind.') This narrative of conscious intergenerational rupture-with-acknowledgement is one of the most psychologically nuanced in Maithili fiction.

The fourth theme is the Pen Friend story ('Pen Friend', pp. 21–24), which explores the ambiguous emotional intimacy of written correspondence across social distance, anticipating the digital-era questions of parasocial connection and identity.

### *5.2.3 Narrative Technique*

Panna Jha's narrative technique is characteristically restrained. She uses free indirect discourse to embed the psychological states of her protagonists within third-person narration, without authorial intrusion or explanation. Dialogue is

used economically — each line carries weight. The settings are drawn from the social world she knows directly: hospital waiting rooms, college classrooms, middle-class Maithil households, political meetings. The linguistic register is clean, contemporary Maithili with minimal Sanskritisation, accessible to educated Maithili readers while maintaining literary precision.

## 5.3 Anusheelan (2012): Essay Collection

### *5.3.1 Structure and Intellectual Ambition*

Anusheelan (Practice / Cultivation — in the sense of disciplined inquiry) is Panna Jha's only essay collection, published by Antika Prakashan in 2012. Its seventeen essays span literary criticism, feminist social analysis, psychological commentary, and cultural studies — the broadest intellectual range of any single-author Maithili essay collection by a woman writer. The folio publisher writes it is 'A Collection of Maithili Essays'. The opening essay 'Sahitya aa Sahitya-Drishti' (Literature and Literary Vision) caused particular discussion: noted critic Mohan Bhardwaj called it the 'reactive text' to the crisis of Maithili literature, categorising its essays under two broad types — literary criticism and knowledge-science expansion.

### *5.3.2 Feminist Literary Criticism*

The essays on women constitute the intellectual centre of the collection. 'Prachin Bharatiya Sanskriti me Nari' (Woman in Ancient Indian Culture) traces the evolution of women's status across Vedic, Epic, and medieval periods, arguing against a simplistic 'golden age' narrative while recovering genuine traditions of women's learning and autonomy. 'Samajak Sashaktikaran me Maithil Mahilak Yogdan' (Maithil Women's Contribution to Social Empowerment) documents the historical and contemporary role of Maithili women in education, literature, and social reform. 'Aadhunik Maithili Kathaa me Nari' (Woman in Modern Maithili Fiction) is a sustained literary-critical essay covering the representation of women across major works of Maithili fiction.

'Beti: Srijan aa Sangharshak Roop' (The Daughter: Creator and Fighter) concludes with the formulation that has been most widely quoted: 'Whether son or daughter, the family's all-round protection and cooperation is essential for their development. What is needed is to save daughters from social, physical, and psychological enslavement. If woman is liberated from the form of goddess and given merely a human form, allowed to develop all-roundly,

then she herself will prove to be the creator, protector, and the one who turns earth into heaven.' This is a direct critique of both the elevation of women to goddess-hood (which removes them from human agency) and their reduction to objects of patriarchal management.

### *5.3.3 Psychological and Social Essays*

The second category of essays in Anusheelan draws on her professional expertise: 'Aatmahatya: Maansik Vikriti' (Suicide: Mental Disorder) analyses the psychological and social causes of suicide with clinical precision, while 'Hinataak Bhavnaa evam Takar Nidaan' (The Feeling of Inferiority and Its Solution) applies Adlerian psychology to the social problem of self-deprecation in Maithili communities. 'Baal Aparaadh: Samajik Abhishaap' (Child Crime: A Social Curse) and 'Bhrashtachar: Kaaran aa Nidaan' (Corruption: Causes and Solutions) connect her psychological expertise to the public policy domain — the same domain her husband addresses from an economic perspective. The parallel is instructive: together the couple address Mithila's crisis from psychology (Panna) and economics (Narendra), producing between them a complementary analytical portrait of the region.

### *5.3.4 Literary and Cultural Essays*

'Maithili-Natak evam Kalkattaak Avadan' (Maithili Drama and Calcutta's Contribution) is the most historically detailed essay in the collection, documenting the role of the Calcutta Maithili community in sustaining and developing Maithili theatrical performance through the twentieth century. This essay is partly autobiographical — Panna Jha lived in Calcutta during the 1960s and was part of the literary circles that sustained Maithili culture in exile.

## 5.4 Abhilasha (2021): Short Story Collection

### *5.4.1 Evolution from Anubhuti*

Abhilasha (Desire / Aspiration), published in 2021 by Antika Prakashan Pvt. Ltd., is Panna Jha's third and final major Maithili work. The author's own preface ('Monak Gapp', pp. XIII–XV) situates the collection in relation to her first: some stories that were ready for Anubhuti (2009/2010) — published earlier in Mithila Darshan, Karnaamrit, and Ghar-Bahar — were collected here after physical health limitations delayed the project. The collection takes aspiration itself as its central subject: every person is surrounded by desire in different forms — desire for learning, desire for offspring, filial piety, accumulation of wealth, love.

Gaurinath's foreword (Sahodi Divas, 23 March 2021) and Bhimnaath Jha's preface (Darbhanga, 01 February 2021) both position Abhilasha as the mature culmination of Panna Jha's fiction, noting the evolution toward greater psychological complexity and social specificity. Bhimnaath Jha writes that the stories are psychologically calibrated (manovaigyanik santulan) and sociologically contextualised, avoiding both exaggeration and sentimentality.

#### *5.4.2 The Opening Story: Gayatri, Shipra, Shruti*

The opening story 'Gayatri, Shipra, Shruti aa Manjit San Bucchhiya Sabhak Man Ke Bujhbaak Aagraha' (An Appeal to Understand the Minds of Children Like Gayatri, Shipra, Shruti and Manjit) sets the thematic key. A girl called Gayatri from a modest family is bright, refined, and interested in academics; she is admitted to a psychology course after scoring 72 per cent. The story then traces what happens when her marriage is arranged to a businessman, abandoning her academic ambitions. The inter-cultural marriage subplot (involving a Punjabi woman character) examines the intersection of class, caste, and aspiration in the modern Maithili social world — exactly the territory where Panna Jha's psychological training and social observation converge.

Bhimnaath Jha's preface notes that Panna Jha is the only contemporary Maithili fiction writer who engages directly with the problems of inter-caste and inter-religious marriage from the perspective of women's agency. This willingness to address what he calls 'the matters that society finds difficult to discuss' — suicide rates, arranged marriage, patriarchal conditioning, aspirational frustration — is central to the ethical and social value of Abhilasha.

## 6. Critical Perspectives: Indian and Western Frameworks

### 6.1 Indian Critical Frameworks

#### *6.1.1 Sahitya Shastra and the Rasa Tradition*

Classical Sanskrit poetics (Sahitya Shastra) provides a productive framework for analysing both Narendra Jha's non-literary writing and Panna Jha's fiction. The concept of rasa — aesthetic emotion distilled from narrative experience — is relevant to Panna Jha's stories in a complex way: her psychological realism suppresses dramatic intensification (the 'rasabhanga' or rasa-spoiling excess

she avoids is precisely what Bhimnaath Jha identifies as absent from her work). Her dominant rasas are karuna (compassion) and shanta (serenity-in-inquiry), the latter appropriate to narratives of psychological acceptance and self-understanding.

For Narendra Jha's writing, the Sahitya Shastra framework is less directly applicable — his work belongs to the 'shastra' (technical treatise) tradition rather than the 'kavya' (literary) tradition. Yet his Preface to Mithila Rising has genuine rhetorical power, evoking the rasa of vira (heroism) and karuna (compassion) in its evocation of Maithil civilisational pride and contemporary humiliation. The Vidyapati title Chapal Charan Chit Chanchal Bhan (a verse about restless youth) applied to his autobiographical text is itself a rasa citation — a deliberate intertextual link to the classical tradition.

### *6.1.2 Postcolonial Indian Criticism and the 'Samanantar Parampara'*

Videha editor Gajendra Thakur's framework of 'Samanantar Parampara' (Parallel Tradition) provides the most relevant Indian critical framework for understanding both Jhas. The Parallel Tradition argues that the official Sahitya Akademi canon of Maithili literature has systematically excluded: (a) Dalit and subaltern voices; (b) women's writing; (c) non-literary, knowledge-productive writing; and (d) regional and dialectal variation. Narendra Jha's economic writing is 'parallel' in all these senses — not Dalit in its authorship but marginalised by the literary establishment's failure to recognise economic analysis as legitimate intellectual production. Panna Jha's feminist essays and psychologically-grounded fiction occupy a parallel position to the predominantly male-authored, romantically or mythologically oriented mainstream Maithili literary canon.

### *6.1.3 Subaltern Studies and Internal Colonialism*

The subaltern studies tradition (Guha, Spivak, Chakrabarty) provides a framework for Narendra Jha's structural argument: Mithila is not simply 'underdeveloped' in the abstract 'development economics' sense, but specifically subordinated through a political mechanism — what he calls the conspiracy of the Magadha-oriented Bihar administration to prevent Mithila from developing sufficient economic independence to seek statehood. This is a theory of internal colonialism: the Bihar state acts as a colonial power over Mithila, extracting resources while suppressing institutional development. The subaltern studies contribution is to situate this not as an accident or backwardness but as an outcome of deliberate political-economic calculation.

### *6.1.4 Indian Feminist Literary Theory*

Panna Jha's Anusheelan is best read in the context of Indian feminist literary criticism as developed by Susie Tharu and K. Lalita in Women Writing in India (1991–2003), which established the framework for recovering women's voices across Indian literatures. Panna Jha's essay 'Nari-Lekhanak Kathaa-Dishaa' (The Story-Direction of Women Writers) is itself a contribution to this feminist literary history project within Maithili: she documents the emergence and development of Maithili women's writing, identifies its distinctive concerns (domestic space, social constraint, aspirational frustration), and argues for its importance in the larger literary tradition. Her positioning of woman not as goddess or victim but as a reasoning, aspiring, socially embedded agent is consistent with what Uma Chakravarti calls 'brahmanical patriarchy' critique within the Indian feminist tradition.

## 6.2 Western Critical Frameworks

### *6.2.1 Gramsci's Organic Intellectualism*

Antonio Gramsci's concept of the 'organic intellectual' — one who arises from a particular social class or community and serves as its intellectual voice, translating lived experience into systematic knowledge — is the most apt Western theoretical framework for Narendra Jha. He is not an academic economist but a Chartered Accountant with fifty years of professional practice in Patna — embedded in the Mithila economic world that he analyses. His knowledge is organic to the community: he attends the same institutions, experiences the same electricity failures, floods, and bureaucratic corruption that he documents. Gramsci distinguishes the organic intellectual from the 'traditional intellectual' (the academic or priestly class that serves the dominant order): Jha writes explicitly against the interests of the Bihar administrative establishment, making him organic to the Maithili subaltern position within the Bihar state structure.

### *6.2.2 Amartya Sen's Capabilities Approach*

Amartya Sen's Capabilities Approach — developed in Development as Freedom (1999) — argues that development should be measured not by GDP growth but by the expansion of real freedoms and capabilities: health, education, political participation, and economic opportunity. This framework aligns directly with Narendra Jha's diagnostic method, which consistently evaluates Mithila's condition not through abstract economic indicators but

through the lived capabilities of its population: can people access water? Can farmers sell their produce at fair prices? Can women participate in public life? Can children attend schools? The correspondence is not coincidental — both Sen and Jha are Bihar-trained economists (Sen at Patna University) whose intellectual formation is shaped by the experience of poverty and underdevelopment in the Gangetic plains.

### *6.2.3 Postcolonial Theory: Beyond Eurocentrism*

Homi Bhabha's concept of 'mimicry and ambivalence' is relevant to Narendra Jha's strategic use of English in Mithila Rising. By writing in English for a national audience, Jha performs a kind of colonial mimicry — adopting the language of the power structure to address it — while simultaneously undermining it through the force of the Maithili-specific data and arguments he deploys. The book's cover painting by Sunita Jha is a Madhubani folk art rendering — a visual assertion of Maithili cultural identity that refuses the 'colonial' logic of the English text itself. This produces Bhabha's 'third space': neither purely Maithili nor purely national-English, but a hybrid that negotiates between the two.

Gayatri Spivak's question 'Can the Subaltern Speak?' is answered differently by the two Jhas. Narendra Jha speaks as a relatively privileged CA (not a subaltern in economic terms) on behalf of a subaltern region — the classic problem of representation. Panna Jha, writing about Maithili women's struggles from within the social world she inhabits, stands closer to the mode of subaltern self-representation, though she too writes from a position of professional and social advantage.

### *6.2.4 Ecofeminism and Water Politics*

Vandana Shiva's ecofeminist analysis in Staying Alive (1988) — arguing that the destruction of natural systems (forests, rivers) and the oppression of women share the same logic of patriarchal extraction — provides a compelling framework for reading Jha's water politics in relation to Panna Jha's feminist writing. Narendra Jha's 2006 volume documents the systematic destruction of Mithila's river systems through embankment culture; Panna Jha's essays and stories document the systematic destruction of women's agency through patriarchal culture. Both forms of extraction — ecological and social — are driven by the same logic of control over the reproductive capacities of nature and women. The dampati lekhaka (couple-writers) framework, in this light, is

not merely biographical but structural: their intellectual projects are complementary critiques of the same system of domination.

### *6.2.5 Psychoanalytic Literary Criticism*

Panna Jha's fiction is particularly amenable to psychoanalytic reading, given her professional background in psychology. Jacques Lacan's concept of the 'mirror stage' — the moment of misrecognition in which the subject identifies with an image of itself — is thematically relevant to Anubhuti's 'Punaravritti' (Repetition), where the protagonist recognises that she is repeating her father's behavioural pattern. Karen Horney's theory of basic anxiety and social neurosis, developed in The Neurotic Personality of Our Time (1937), directly informs Anusheelan's essay on inferiority (hinataak bhavnaa) and the suicide essay — both of which analyse social maladaptation as a response to impossible social expectations rather than individual pathology.

Alfred Adler's theory of inferiority complex and the compensatory will to power is explicitly present in Anusheelan's psychological essays. Panna Jha's contribution is to apply these Western psychological frameworks to specifically Maithili social conditions: the caste hierarchies, dowry system, joint family structure, and arranged marriage institutions that produce the distinctive forms of anxiety and aspiration she documents in her fiction.

### *6.2.6 Narrative Theory: Form and Realism*

From the perspective of Western narrative theory (Genette, Booth, Bakhtin), Panna Jha's fiction operates within the tradition of psychological realism as theorised by Mikhail Bakhtin in The Dialogic Imagination (1981). Her stories are characteristically dialogic — populated by multiple voices (the patient, the doctor, the family, the institution) that are not resolved into a single authoritative perspective. The narrative voice typically hovers between the protagonist's internal world and the social world that constrains her, producing what Bakhtin calls 'double-voiced discourse' — language that carries both the character's perspective and the social judgment that oppresses her.

Wayne Booth's concept of the 'implied author' is relevant to the ethical dimension of Panna Jha's work: the implied author of Anubhuti and Abhilasha is consistently compassionate, analytically precise, and implicitly critical of patriarchal social structures, without ever lapsing into didacticism. This balance — showing suffering without simplifying its causes — is the technical achievement that reviewers (including Bhimnaath Jha and Hitnaath Jha) identify as the distinctive quality of her craft.

## 7. The Dampati Lekhaka (Couple-Writers) Tradition

The concept of dampati lekhaka — husband-and-wife writing partnerships in Maithili — has a precedent in the tradition of Maithili literature, but the Jha couple represents its most intellectually developed form. Their partnership is not merely biographical proximity but a genuine intellectual complementarity: Narendra's economic-political analysis and Panna's psychological-feminist analysis together produce a comprehensive portrait of Maithili society that neither could have produced alone.

The dedication and acknowledgement pages of each other's works signal this mutual intellectual debt. Panna Jha's Anusheelan preface acknowledges Narendra Jha's sustained support ('my husband Shri Narendra Jha from his private library with care provided constant assistance'). Narendra Jha's books carry preface notes by the poet Agnipushpa (his younger brother) — and Agnipushpa is interestingly noted to be opposed to the Mithila statehood argument, creating an intra-family intellectual tension.

The geographical trajectory also parallels each other: both lived in Calcutta during the 1960s — where the Maithili literary and social world was particularly vibrant — before relocating to Patna in 1975, where both continued to engage with Maithili institutional life while pursuing their respective professional careers. Their retirement years (Panna from 2008, Narendra from active CA practice in his late 70s) coincided with their most productive literary periods. Videha Issue 395, by commissioning analyses of both writers simultaneously, formally recognises this dampati lekhaka identity.

## 8. Critical Reception

### 8.1 Reception of Narendra Jha

Videha Issue 395 represents the first systematic critical reception of Narendra Jha's work. Prior to this, his books were used as reference material but rarely subjected to scholarly literary analysis. The seventeen essays in the special number represent a cross-section of critical opinion across Bihar and the Maithili diaspora.

- Ajit Kumar Jha (title: ‘Mithilak Arthashastri’ / Mithila’s Economist): The first public recognition of Jha as an economist in the classical sense — a designation no Maithili writer had received before.
- Ramesh (Darbhanga): The most sustained literary-critical essay, arguing that non-literary writing is the ‘real’ writing — more industrious, more data-dependent, more consequential — and that Jha represents this tradition against the dominant literary establishment.
- Dr. Kailash Kumar Mishra: Analysis of Arthtantra O Bhrashtachar using The Economist Democracy Index as a measure of analytical sophistication unusual for Maithili.
- Madhukant Jha: Appreciates the historical documentary value while critiquing the insufficient prescription for solutions and the relative silence on zamindari history.
- Dr. Dhanakara Thakur: The most critical essay, questioning Jha’s historical analysis for omitting the Darbhanga Raj’s feudal role in Mithila’s economic impoverishment.
- Shailendra Mishra and Pranav Jha: Both affirm Jha’s triple identity as CA, economic-social writer, and Mithila campaigner.
- Ashish Anchinhar: The most theoretically ambitious essay, using the metaphor of ‘malnutrition’ to argue that Jha’s work is indispensable but insufficient — and that responsibility for the thinness of the economic-writing tradition lies with the Maithili literary establishment, not with Jha.

## 8.2 Reception of Panna Jha

Panna Jha’s reception has been more consistently positive, with less internal debate about her methods or positions. Key assessments:

- Dr. Bhimnaath Jha (Preface to Abhilasha, 2021): Identifies her defining characteristic as psychological balance (santulan), noting that her stories avoid both improbability and exaggeration — the two faults of psychological fiction.
- Gaurinath (Preface to Abhilasha, 2021): Positions Panna Jha as Maithili’s foremost psychological-realist fiction writer, noting her direct engagement with taboo subjects (suicide, inter-caste marriage, conjugal violence) from within the social world she inhabits.
- Mohan Bhardwaj (Foreword to Anusheelan, 2012): Distinguishes two streams in Anusheelan — literary criticism and knowledge-science — and reads the first essay as a reactive text to the crisis of Maithili literature.

- Hitnaath Jha (Videha 395, ‘Atmavishvas ka Preranasrot’): The fullest biographical-critical account of Panna Jha’s career, analysing all three Maithili works and situating them within the tradition of Maithili women’s writing since 1965.
- Chetna Samiti, Patna (Tamrapatra citation, 2022): Describes her as ‘inspiration-source for self-confidence among Maithil women, always engaged in the development and preservation of Maithili language-literature.’

# 9. Synthesis: Strengths, Limitations, and Legacy

## 9.1 Narendra Jha: Assessment

### *Strengths*

- Pioneer of economic writing in Maithili, filling a near-total vacuum across five decades of regional language development.
- Combines rare professional expertise (50+ years as CA) with deep regional knowledge and personal engagement with the Mithila movement.
- Empirically rigorous: data-rich, field-informed, with references to primary government sources, international periodicals, and sub-regional economic data.
- Consistent ideological clarity: pro-planned development, anti-corruption, pro-Mithila statehood, pro-equitable water and land management.
- Bilingual reach: Maithili books for the home community, English Mithila Rising for national/global advocacy.
- Available freely at videha.co.in/pothi.htm, making the work accessible to future researchers without cost barrier.

### *Limitations*

- Historical analysis insufficiently critical of feudal-era institutions (Darbhanga Raj zamindari) as a structural cause of Mithila’s economic underdevelopment.
- Books are primarily documentary (data assemblage) rather than prescriptive: strong on diagnosis, weaker on solution-design.
- Some essays are compressed and would benefit from greater analytical depth.

- Inconsistent use of ‘Mithilanchal’ (implying geographic fragmentation) alongside Mithila statehood advocacy.
- The tradition he initiated in Maithili economic writing has not been continued or extended — pointing to a systemic failure of the Maithili literary ecosystem to nurture non-literary writing.

## 9.2 Panna Jha: Assessment

### *Strengths*

- Unique dual expertise: professional psychologist and literary author, producing fiction and essays that are simultaneously analytically grounded and aesthetically refined.
- Consistent feminist perspective across all three Maithili works, without didacticism or polemic.
- Psychological realism of a high order: the balance between character interiority and social context is managed with craft.
- Thematic courage: directly addresses taboo subjects (suicide, inter-caste marriage, patriarchal violence, inferiority complex) in a social world that prefers silence.
- Essay collection Anusheelan: the broadest-ranging single-author essay collection by a woman writer in modern Maithili — literary criticism, feminist sociology, and applied psychology in a single volume.

### *Limitations*

- Output is relatively small (three Maithili books in over sixty years of literary activity), partly due to the competing demands of professional and domestic life.
- Some stories in Anubhuti and Abhilasha remain understated where a more formally ambitious treatment might have been possible.
- The connection between her psychological analyses (in Anusheelan) and the narrative practice (in Anubhuti/Abhilasha) could have been more explicitly theorised.

## 9.3 Legacy

The Jha couple represent, taken together, the most comprehensive attempt in twentieth and twenty-first century Maithili writing to address the civilisational question: what has happened to Mithila, and how can it be recovered? Narendra’s answer is economic and political — through data, advocacy, and

statehood. Panna's answer is psychological and feminist — through the recovery of women's agency and the psycho-social health of the community. Both are necessary. The Videha special issue (395) is the first formal recognition of their combined significance, positioning them not as peripheral regional figures but as foundational contributors to a genuinely democratic, knowledge-productive Maithili literary tradition.

As Ashish Anchinhar puts it: Narendra Jha is a necessary nutritive element for malnourished Maithili literature — but the question of whether his example will generate a tradition rather than remaining an anomaly rests not with Jha himself but with the Maithili literary establishment, academic institutions, and publishing ecosystem that either nourishes or starves non-literary knowledge production in the language. The same question applies to Panna Jha's feminist psychological writing: will Maithili women's fiction develop into a sustained tradition, or will her pioneering remain isolated?

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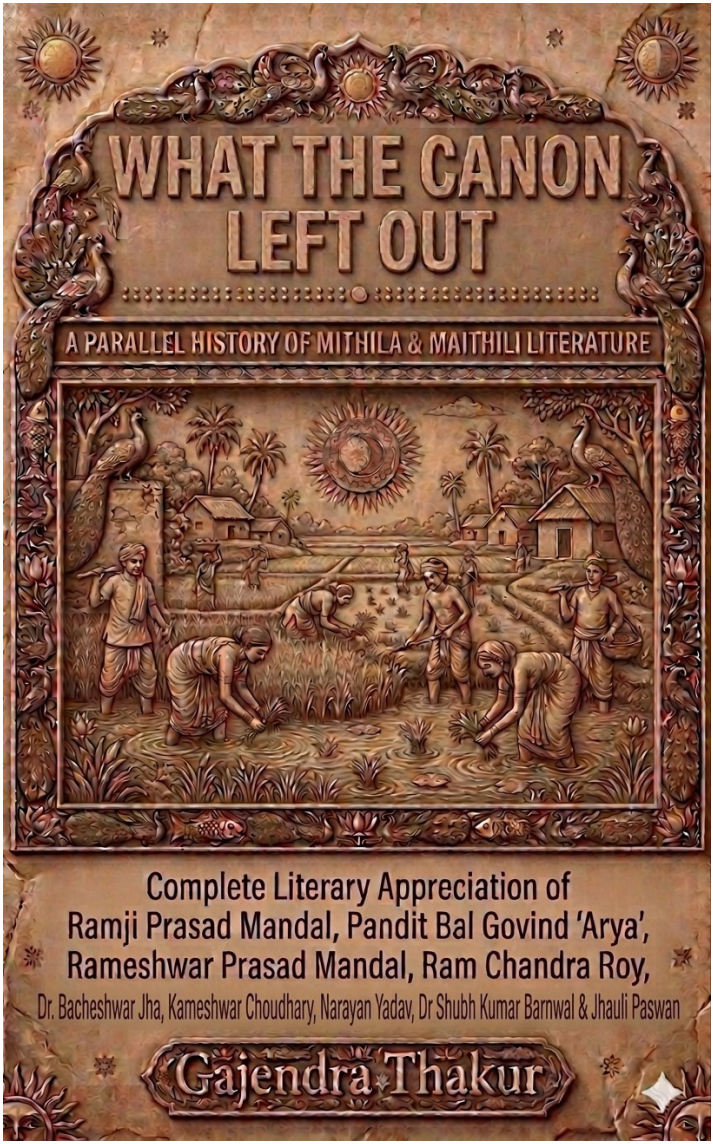
**LESSON 054 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**




## A Critical Compendium of Nine Contemporary Maithili Voices

**Ramji Prasad Mandal, Pt. Bal Govind 'Arya', Rameshwar Prasad Mandal, Ram Chandra Roy, Dr. Bacheshwar Jha, Kameshwar**

**Choudhary, Narayan Yadav, Dr. Shubh Kumar Barnwal, and Jhauli Paswan.**

**A Research and Critical Appreciation**

**Frameworks Applied:**

Indian Classical Criticism (Rasa, Dhvani, Vakrokti, Alamkara)

Western Critical Theory (New Criticism, Post-colonialism, Feminist Theory, Narratology, Formalism, Reader-Response, Post-Structuralism)

Videha Parallel History Framework (Gajendra Thakur / Videha e-Journal)

Navya Nyaya Epistemology (Gangesa Upadhyaya and the Tattva-Cintamani tradition)

## Preface: Methodological Framework

**Methodological Synthesis and Literary Pluralism**

The contemporary literary landscape of the Mithila region, as archived by the pioneering Videha eJournal, presents a vibrant tapestry of voices that resist monolithic interpretation. This critical compendium undertakes a systematic analysis of nine distinctive Maithili authors: **Ramji Prasad Mandal, Pt. Bal Govind 'Arya', Rameshwar Prasad Mandal, Ram Chandra Roy, Dr. Bacheshwar Jha, Kameshwar Choudhary, Narayan Yadav, Dr. Shubh Kumar Barnwal, and Jhauli Paswan.**

To move beyond impressionistic praise and construct a rigorous scholarly evaluation, this study synthesizes multiple critical frameworks:

1. **Western Formalism & Structuralism:** To analyze the internal mechanics of the texts—language, structure, and literary devices (e.g., the fusion of *Charyapada* prosody in 'Bagwar').
2. **Indian Aesthetics (Rasa-Dhvani-Vakrokti):** To appreciate the emotive and suggestive power of the works, identifying the *sthayi bhava* (dominant emotion) that gives rise to *rasa* (aesthetic relish), and the *vakrata* (oblique expression) that creates poetic beauty.
3. **Videha Parallel History Framework (VPHF):** This original framework, derived from the archive's unique function, posits that these texts are not mere reflections of mainstream history but are **counter-narratives**. They operate in a parallel historical dimension, chronicling the experiences, struggles, and philosophies of the marginalized, the rural, and the linguistically specific, thereby challenging the hegemonic discourse of national/colonial history.

4. **Navya Nyaya Epistemology (Technique of Gaṅgeśa):** This medieval school of logic, which emphasizes precise definition (*lakṣaṇa*), categorical distinction (*avacchedakatā*), and reasoned inference (*anumāna*), will be used to analyze the argumentative structure, social critiques, and the process of knowledge construction in the non-fiction works. The rigorous *jalpa* (debate) and *vitaṇḍā* (destructive criticism) methods provide a powerful lens for examining political and social commentary.

The synthesis of these frameworks allows for a multi-layered appreciation: we will first describe the textual form (Formalism), then analyze its emotional and suggestive impact (Indian Aesthetics), place it as a historical counter-narrative (VPHF), and finally, deconstruct its logical propositions (Navya Nyaya).

Each work belongs to the contemporary Maithili parallel literary tradition — a tradition that stands apart from the mainstream upper-caste-dominated Sahitya Akademi circuit and articulates the voices of the socially marginalised, agrarian, and working-class communities of Mithila.

Thus the criticism in this volume is conducted through a convergence of four major analytical lenses:

**1. Indian Classical Criticism:** Drawing on Bharata's Natyashastra (Rasa theory), Anandavardhana's Dhvanyaloka (theory of Dhvani or resonance), Kuntaka's Vakroktijivita (the principle of oblique or defamiliarised expression), and the Alamkara tradition of Bhamaha and Dandin. These tools allow us to measure the aesthetic affect (rasa), the suggested meanings beyond the literal (vyangya), and the rhetorical figures (alamkara) at work in each composition.

**2. Western Critical Theory:** Employing New Critical close reading (I.A. Richards, Cleanth Brooks), Bakhtinian dialogism and heteroglossia, postcolonial theory (Frantz Fanon, Homi Bhabha), feminist narratology (Judith Butler, Sandra Gilbert), and Fredric Jameson's political unconscious to explore ideological dimensions. Particular attention is paid to how the texts construct subjectivity, challenge hegemony, and negotiate with the colonial/caste archive.

**3. The Videha Parallel History Framework:** Articulated by Gajendra Thakur in the Videha e-Journal (ISSN 2229-547X, www.videha.co.in), this framework recognises that Maithili literature has always contained two streams — the mainstream (largely Brahmin-Kayastha) stream supported by official academies, and the parallel tradition composed by Dalit, OBC, and socially excluded voices. The Videha framework insists that literary history must be written from below, taking into account caste, class, and gender dynamics. Works analysed here all belong to, or are deeply informed by, this parallel

tradition. The framework also draws on Thakur's method of genealogical mapping (Panji Prabandh) to situate authors within historically verifiable socio-cultural matrices.

**4. Navya Nyaya Epistemology:** Developed by Gangesa Upadhyaya of Mithila (13th–14th century CE) in his Tattva-Cintamani, and extended by Raghunatha Shiromani, Mathuranatha Tarkavagisha, and Jagadisha Tarkālamkara, Navya Nyaya offers a highly precise logical-linguistic toolkit for analysing knowledge claims. Applied to literary criticism, it enables us to interrogate the propositional content of a poem or narrative: What is the anuvyavasaya (meta-cognition of a cognition) at work? Is the literary claim a perceptual (pratyaksha), inferential (anumana), or testimony-based (shabda) truth? The technique of vishesha-tabhava analysis (the relation between qualifier, qualificand, and the limiting relation) illuminates how authors build meaning through specifically structured word-images. Navya Nyaya's insistence on disambiguation — on separating the lakshana (definition) from its vyapti (pervasion) — sharpens reading of metaphorical and symbolic density in these Maithili texts.

The  works represent a spectrum of genres: poetry (kavya sangrah), a grammar text (vyakaran bhumika), a novel (upanyas), a narrative-poetry stream (kavyadhara), short fiction (katha sangrah), historical reminiscences (smarananjali), and another poetry anthology. Their common thread is social commitment, linguistic innovation in the Maithili vernacular, and an insistence on recovering subaltern life-experience from invisibility.

I

**Ramji Prasad Mandal**

**Poetic Landscapes of Resistance & Remembrance: Ramji Prasad Mandal**

Ramji Prasad Mandal is among the most prolific Maithili poets emerging from the parallel literary tradition of Supaul district. His works in this collection — the poetry anthology Lal Rang Chahait Achhi Roti (2023), chart a sustained engagement with questions of labour, dignity, womanhood, spiritual eclecticism, and the aesthetics of political longing.

**Ramji Prasad Mandal: The Lyrical Ethos of Subaltern Dignity**

**Work:** *Lāl Raṅg Chāhat Achi Roṭī* (लाल रंग चाहैत अछि रोटी - Red Craves the Bread)

**Formalist-Structuralist Analysis:** Mandal’s collection is a powerful exercise in poetic economy. The dominant form is the short, free-verse lyric, often

utilizing stark imagery and direct address. His language is a deliberate choice: it is not the Sanskritized *Śiṣṭa* Maithili but the raw, spoken dialect of the agrarian poor. This formal choice is the poem's primary structure; the unadorned, sometimes fragmented syntax mirrors the fragmented lives of his subjects. The title poem's central metaphor—'red' bread—is a brilliant synecdoche, where the color red stands for the laborer's blood, passion, and struggle, while the 'roṭī' (bread) is the fundamental object of survival. The *Vakrokti* (obliquity) lies in the personification: the bread itself "desires" its red color, making the demand for justice intrinsic to existence.

**Indian Aesthetics (Rasa-Dhvani):** The dominant *sthāyi bhāva* is *karuṇa* (pathos) and *raudra* (fury). The poems, such as 'असमर्थ छी बेटीकेँ जन्म देबएमे' (Asamarth Chī Beṭīkaṁ Janma Debēmē - Unable to give birth to a daughter), do not just describe sorrow; they *perform* it. The *dhvani* (suggestion) is deeply layered. The explicit meaning is a father's lament, but the suggested meaning is a scathing indictment of a patriarchal, dowry-ridden society that devalues female birth. The *rasa* produced is not pure pathos but a bitter *karuṇa* tinged with *vībhatsa* (disgust) at the social order, forcing the reader into an uncomfortable state of moral outrage.

**Videha Parallel History Framework (VPHF):** Mandal’s poetry functions as an **archive of rural pain**. The mainstream narrative of post-Independence India is one of progress and development. Mandal offers a parallel history—a chronicle of the "other" India. His poem 'फेंकाएल जिनगी' (Phenkāēl Jinagī - Thrown-away Life) is not a fictional tragedy; it is a documented reality of social abandonment. This framework reveals that the "development" celebrated in cities is built on the "thrown-away lives" of the rural poor. His work is a counter-memory to the nationalist amnesia regarding internal colonialism and caste-based oppression.

**Navya Nyaya Critique:** The poem 'नव-वर्ष' (Nav-Varṣ - New Year) can be analyzed as a *jalpa* (debate) with the concept of time. The poet poses a series of logical challenges (*nigrahasthāna* - points of defeat) to the very idea of celebrating a new year while social realities remain unchanged. He uses inference (*anumāna*): observing the suffering of the poor (*hetu* - reason), he infers the fallacy (*hetvābhāsa*) of the celebratory rituals, which are based on a false premise of universal joy. This is a Navya Nyaya technique of deconstructing a cultural proposition by exposing its insufficient logical grounds.

## Lal Rang Chahait Achhi Roti (लाल रंग चाहैत अछि रोटी) — Poetry Anthology, 2023

### *Bibliographic Details*

ISBN: 978-93-93135-55-1. First edition 2023. Pallavi Publication, Nirmali, Supaul. 62 pp. Price: ₹100. Typography: Dr. Umesh Mandal. Cover design: Smt. Punam Mandal.

### *Overview and Genre*

Lal Rang Chahait Achhi Roti (Red Wants the Bread) is a lean, politically charged kavya sangrah (poetry anthology) of approximately twenty-two poems in Maithili. The title poem — and indeed the volume's governing conceit — superimposes the red of hunger, the red of revolution, and the red of ritual at once: the roti (bread) that desires the red signifier of both blood and vermilion. This is an ekphrastic move that Kuntaka would categorise as vakrokti of the second order — a semantic obliqueness achieved not through unusual grammar but through the audacious yoking of the political with the quotidian domestic.

### *Thematic Architecture*

The collection opens with "Hammr Jalisa" (My Assembly/Longing), a poem of literary self-inventory in which the speaker rehearses his debts to Maithili's founding genius Vidyapati (Kirtilata, Kirtipataaka, the Padavali) while asserting the claim of a vernacular, folk-embedded, mixed-register Maithili. This is precisely the move that the Videha Parallel History Framework valorises: the deliberate claiming of classical ancestry by a non-Brahmin poet, challenging the monopoly that the mainstream stream has exercised over the Vidyapati legacy. The poem performs what Homi Bhabha terms "sly civility" — inhabiting the canonical while subverting its exclusive ownership.

The middle section of the collection moves into social poetry. "Dal Daldal Mein Neta Upar" (Leaders float on the swamp) deploys the classical rasa of bibhatsa (disgust) as a political instrument — a strategy consonant with Bharata's eighth rasa but rarely explored in modern Maithili verse. The poem's imagery of political leaders floating above the swamp of public suffering while the people sink recalls Brecht's Verfremdungseffekt in its deliberate refusal of lyrical consolation.

"Lal Rang Chahait Achhi Roti" (the title poem) demonstrates Dhvani at its most concentrated. On the surface level (vaachya), the poem describes a hungry person's wish for bread with a red colour — perhaps red lentil, perhaps saffron-stained. But the dhvanyartha (resonant meaning) vibrates with revolutionary suggestion: the bread wants redness because redness is what the working body bleeds; redness is what the Left promises; redness is what is daily denied. In Navya Nyaya terms, the qualificand (roti) and its qualifier (lal rang) are held in an unusual vyapti (pervasion-relation) that shatters their ordinary logical connection, forcing the reader to reconstruct the anuvyavasaya — the meta-cognition that asks: "What kind of knowing does this red-bread conjunction produce?"

### *The Poems on Womanhood*

The third thematic cluster — comprising "Asmath Ki Beti Ko Janm Dene Mein" (On the Difficulty of Bearing a Daughter), "Ajamma Beti Ki Manuhaar" (The Unborn Daughter's Entreaty), and "Shram Shakti" (Power of Labour) — constitutes perhaps the most remarkable feminist Maithili poetry outside the Videha archive. The unborn daughter's poem is a monologue in which a foetus speaks to her mother, promising to rival Kalpana Chawla, Kiran Bedi, and Hema Das — real women whose embodied achievements are invoked as counter-narratives to patriarchal infanticide. This is what Sandra Gilbert and Susan Gubar would call "the anxiety of authorship" reversed: here, the female subject writes herself into existence before birth, claiming the archive of achieved women against the annihilation her society plans.

Navya Nyaya analysis of "Ajamma Beti Ki Manuhaar" reveals a complex structure of pratijnya (proposition): the daughter argues by anumana (inference): "Since these women (Sita, Radha, Draupadi, Kiran Bedi, Hema Das) exist and are valued, and since I am of the same class/gender, therefore I also deserve to exist." The inference is valid (vyapti-baddha), but the society's counter-premise — that a daughter is economically burdensome — constitutes a dushana (defeater) that the poem systematically dismantles verse by verse.

### *Stylistics and Language*

Mandal's Maithili is a genuinely mixed koine — tatsama, tadbhava, deshaj, and loanwords from Hindi and English coexist without anxiety. This is the linguistic programme announced in "Hammr Jalisa": Vidyapati himself used multiple registers, and Mandal's eclecticism is a form of historical fidelity rather than contamination. The Videha framework explicitly defends this

mixed-register Maithili against the purism of the mainstream stream which, as Gajendra Thakur has documented, uses linguistic gatekeeping as a tool of caste exclusion.

### *Critical Assessment*

Lal Rang Chahait Achhi Roti is a modest but morally urgent collection. Its weaknesses lie in occasional prosodic irregularity and some poems where the didactic intent overwhelms the aesthetic impulse — a tension that the Indian rasa tradition marks as the subordination of shringara and karuna rasas to vira and raudra, not always successfully balanced. However, the best poems — the title poem, the unborn daughter's appeal, and "Shram Shakti" — achieve what Anandavardhana called dhvani of the highest order: where the suggested meaning completely dominates the expressed meaning, making the poem inexhaustible on re-reading. Within the Videha Parallel History Framework, this collection is significant as evidence of a non-Brahmin, subaltern male poet reclaiming classical Maithili genres for politically radical purposes.

Mandal's poetic universe is structured around two axes: the axis of memory (the inherited aesthetic canon of Maithili from Vidyapati to the folk-oral tradition) and the axis of urgency (the present crises of hunger, caste violence, female foeticide, and rural dispossession). His technique consistently involves superimposing these axes — so that a poem about the new year (Nav Varsh) becomes a critique of the Westernisation of festivals, and a poem about Ahalya's monologue becomes an exploration of structural violence against women within the mythological archive.

Using the Vakrokti lens of Kuntaka, Mandal's characteristic move is what Kuntaka calls varna-vinyasa vakrokti — unusual sound-patterning that creates a secondary semantic charge. The compound "lal-rang chahait achhi roti" achieves this through the chiasmic reversal of agent and object: it is the bread (object) that desires the colour (qualifier), not the poet or the poor person who desires coloured bread. This inversion is a grammatical vakrokti that throws the entire ideological weight onto the desired object — the bread itself becomes political consciousness.

In terms of the Navya Nyaya analysis of his complete poetic project, Mandal works with what Gangesa would call sannikarsha — the special contact relation between a word and the object it cognises. Mandal's poetic labour is to disrupt normalised sannikarsha relations (roti = domestic, lal = auspicious) by establishing new, unprecedented vyapti (pervasion) relations that force the

reader into fresh cognitive labour. This is the epistemological function of his poetry: to make the reader relearn the world.

II

**Pt. Bal Govind 'Arya': The Grammarian as a Cultural Archivist**

**Work:** *Varṇa Prakaraṇa Bhāṣya-Bhūmikā* (वर्ण प्रकरण भाष्य-भूमिका - A Commentary on the Science of Phonetics)

**Formalist-Structuralist Analysis:** This is a pedagogical grammar. Its structure is classical: it begins with a definition of grammar (*vyākaraṇa*), then proceeds through *varṇa* (phoneme), *akṣara* (syllable), *sandhi* (euphonic combination), and so on. Each section is framed as a *praśna* (question) and *uttara* (answer), mimicking the oral pedagogical tradition. The structure is not just descriptive but prescriptive, establishing rules for "correct" Maithili. The inclusion of a section on English spelling rules (*Śuddha-Śuddha Aṅgrezī Lilek Niyam*) is a remarkable structural hybrid, acknowledging the new linguistic reality while asserting Maithili's grammatical framework.

**Indian Aesthetics (Rasa-Dhvani):** While a grammar is not typically analyzed for *rasa*, the *bhāṣya* (commentary) form has its own aesthetic. The *śānta rasa* (peace of clarity) is the goal: the satisfaction that comes from understanding a complex system. The *dhvani* of the entire work is the subtle assertion of Maithili's classical status. By analyzing its phonetics with the same tools used for Sanskrit, the book *suggests* that Maithili is a language of science and high culture, not just a *deśī bhāṣā* (vernacular). The *vakratā* is in the apparent simplicity; the straight, didactic style conceals a profound political act of linguistic empowerment.

**Videha Parallel History Framework (VPHF):** This work is a **parallel history of linguistic standardization**. Mainstream histories of Indian languages often focus on Sanskrit, Hindi, or English. Arya's grammar is a *parallel archive* of Maithili's internal logic and systematic rules. It rejects the history of Maithili as a "dialect" and constructs a history of it as a *vyākaraṇa-samūrddha* (grammatically-rich) language. The tables of phonemes and rules of *sandhi* are not just pedagogical tools; they are documentary evidence for Maithili's independent and scientific structure, countering narratives of its subordination.

**Navya Nyaya Critique:** The entire grammar is an exercise in *paribhāṣā* (meta-rule). Navya Nyaya is concerned with the precise definition

of terms (*lakṣaṇa*). Arya's work is a series of such definitions. What is a *varṇa*? What is an *akṣara*? He provides the *svarūpa lakṣaṇa* (essential definition) of each unit. The sections on *sandhi* apply the logical principle of *saṃyoga* (conjunction) and *vibhāga* (division). The rules are presented as invariable concomitance (*vyāpti*): given 'a' + 'a', the outcome is invariably 'ā'. This is a grammatical application of the Nyaya principle of cause and effect (*kārya-kāraṇa*).

## Pandit Bal Govind 'Arya' Varna Prakarana Bhashya-Bhumika/ Non-Fiction as a Mode of Cultural Memory

### *Bibliographic Details*

Full title (Maithili): Varna Prakarana Bhashya-Bhumika (वर्ण प्रकरण भाष्य-भूमिका) — A Maithili Grammar by Pandit Bal Govind 'Arya'. ISBN: 978-93-88811-49-1. First edition: 2020. Price: ₹250. Pallavi Publication, Nirmali. 134 pp.

### *Nature of the Text*

This is a grammar text — a vyakaran prabandha — treating the Maithili language from the perspective of varna (phoneme/character), pada (word/case), vakya (sentence/syntax), vinyaas (punctuation), and chandashastra (prosody). The work is divided into two major sections: Prakarana (Chapter) 1, dealing with descriptive grammar (orthography, morphology, syntax, punctuation, prosody); and Prakarana 2, with an extended treatment of tones and euphonics. A brief appendix on Maithili manuscript study (Mithilakshar lipi) is also provided.

### *Place in Maithili Grammatical Tradition*

The grammatical study of Maithili has a distinguished history: George Grierson's survey work on Maithili dialects (Linguistic Survey of India, 1903) represents the colonial-era moment; S.K. Chatterjee's researches in the early twentieth century confirmed Maithili's status as an independent language; and subsequent grammarians have worked within both mainstream and parallel traditions. Pandit Bal Govind 'Arya's contribution is unusual in that it is written from within a practical-pedagogical tradition: the preface (as interpreted from the extant typeset pages) indicates that this grammar was designed for students

in classes 10 to 12 who are learning Maithili as a subject. This is a grammar of use, not of display.

The Videha Parallel History Framework is directly relevant here. Gajendra Thakur has consistently documented how official Maithili grammars have been constructed primarily around the Brahmin-Kayastha literary koine, excluding the Maithili of Dalit, Yadav, Kushwaha, and other communities. Arya's grammar, originating in the Pallavi Publication milieu, implicitly challenges this monopoly: it presents a pedagogically neutral, non-exclusionary account of Maithili phonology and syntax that does not privilege any one dialectal prestige form.

### *Analytical Framework: Navya Nyaya and the Grammar of Knowing*

A grammar text is, in the Navya Nyaya frame, a treatise on shabda-pramana — knowledge derived from verbal testimony. The Navya Naiyayikas, especially Gangesa in the Tattvacintamani (Shabda-khanda), analyse how a sentence (vakya) conveys knowledge, with particular attention to tatparya (the speaker's intention) and its role in disambiguating syntactic structures. Arya's treatment of punctuation (vinyaas) and syntax (vakya-prakarana) maps closely onto the Navya Nyaya concern with how syntactic markers guide the reconstruction of the speaker's tatparya. His classification of pause-markers (ardha-viram, poorna-viram, prashna-chinh) mirrors the Navya Nyaya distinction between incomplete cognition and complete cognition (paryavasana).

From the Western critical perspective, this grammar belongs to the tradition of pedagogical linguistics that Foucault associates with "disciplinary knowledge" — but in the context of a minority language, the discipline of grammar is also a form of cultural resistance. By codifying Maithili phonology, morphology, and prosody in a form accessible to school students, Arya performs an act of linguistic sovereignty. This resonates with what Ngugi wa Thiong'o calls "decolonising the mind" through the mother tongue: the grammar becomes a counter-archive against the Hindi-dominant educational system.

### *Technical Assessment*

The text's treatment of Maithili chandas (prosody) — particularly the classification of metres into maatravrtta (mora-based) and varnavrtta (syllabic) systems — is competent and pedagogically clear. The discussion of sandhis (euphonic combinations) and vibhakti (case endings) draws on the Ashtadhyayi tradition but adapts it to Maithili's agglutinative tendencies. The section on Mithilakshar script (the indigenous Tirhuta script of Maithili) is brief but

important: it acknowledges that Maithili's full heritage is inseparable from its script tradition, which Gajendra Thakur has worked extensively to preserve and digitise.

### *Critical Assessment*

Varna Prakarana Bhashya-Bhumika is a significant if modest contribution to the pedagogical grammar of Maithili. Its value lies less in theoretical innovation than in practical accessibility. Within the Videha Parallel History Framework, any act of codifying and teaching Maithili grammar outside the official academic-Akademi nexus is politically charged. This grammar belongs to the infrastructure of language maintenance for the next generation of Maithili speakers, particularly those from communities historically excluded from the literary establishment.

III

## Rameshwar Prasad Mandal: The Epic of the Mundane and the Novel of the Masses

**Work:** *Bagwār* (बगवार - A Poetic Novel) & *Baukī* (बौकी - The Mute Girl)

**Formalist-Structuralist Analysis:** Mandal’s genius lies in genre experimentation. *Bagwār* is a **poetic novel** (*kāvya-upanyās*), a rare form. It uses the *dohā* and *chaupaī* meters, traditionally reserved for mythological or heroic tales, to narrate the life of an ordinary farmer, Jagū. This structural choice creates an epic dignity for a subaltern life. *Baukī* is a social realist novel, but its structure is built around the title character's muteness. The narrative's silences, gaps, and use of non-verbal communication (gestures, "ईऽऽ ईऽऽ उऽऽ") become a powerful structural device, forcing the reader to experience the protagonist's isolation.

**Indian Aesthetics (Rasa-Dhvani):** *Bagwār* primarily evokes *vīra* (heroism in struggle) and *śānta* (peace in acceptance). The *dhvani* is of the dignity of labor. The poem 'माछक चोहर' (Māchak Chohar - The Theft of Fish) suggests not just a crime but a violation of a man's life's work, making the *raudra* (fury) of injustice felt deeply. In *Baukī*, the dominant *rasa* is *karuṇa* (pathos) leading to *adbhuta* (wonder) at the protagonist's resilience. The *vakratā* is extreme: the most powerful moments are when the protagonist, who cannot speak, tries to communicate. Her gestures are the *vakrokti*, a "crooked speech" that is more eloquent than any direct dialogue could be.

**Videha Parallel History Framework (VPHF):** *Bagwār* is a **parallel history of the Indian peasant**. It counters the elite narratives of the Green Revolution by showing the personal cost and the persistence of precarity. The hero, Jagū, doesn't overthrow a government; he builds a school and a hospital. This is a history of micro-development and community building, which is parallel to, but more fundamental than, state-led development. *Baukī* is a **parallel history of the disabled**. It rejects the history of pity or magical cure. Instead, it chronicles the history of agency, showing how a "mute girl" uses her intelligence and will to navigate, survive, and ultimately triumph over a world that sees her as an object, not a subject.

**Navya Nyaya Critique:** In *Baukī*, the character of Sarpanch Vinash Pandit operates on a system of fallacious logic (*hetvābhāsa*). He tries to prove that Bauki should be sent to a temple based on the *hetu* (reason) that she is a burden. The novel, as a whole, deconstructs his logic through the *anumāna* (inference) of Bauki's actions. By showing her intelligence, loyalty, and capacity for love, the narrative provides a counter-*hetu*: she is a capable human being. The entire novel is a *khaṇḍana* (refutation) of the *pūrva-pakṣa* (prima facie view) of society towards the disabled. The logical proof is not an argument but the entire narrative of her life.

## Rameshwar Prasad Mandal — Baukee (Novel) & Bagwar (Kavyadhara)

Rameshwar Prasad Mandal is a retired schoolteacher from Supaul whose literary career has focused on the social novel and narrative verse. The prakashan note in Baukee describes him as having spent a lifetime educating children while also serving as a committed Maithili writer. He is positioned, in the Pallavi imprint, as a direct inheritor of the social realist tradition associated with Jagadish Prasad Mandal (Sahitya Akademi awardee for his novel Panga, 2021), whose Hindi translation Rameshwar Prasad Mandal himself undertook.

### Baukee (बौकी) — Maithili Novel, 2024

#### *Bibliographic Details*

ISBN: 978-93-93135-56-8. First edition: 2024. Price: ₹250. Pallavi Publication, Nirmali. 116 pp. Cover: Smt. Punam Mandal. Typography: Dr. Umesh Mandal.

### *Plot and Narrative Structure*

Baukee (meaning "a mute/dumb girl" in regional dialect, also carrying connotations of simplicity and groundedness) is a social novel centring on a girl who is abandoned as an orphan and is mute — classified as "bauki" (differently abled) by her society. The novel traces her trajectory from social rejection to a position of authority as a police sub-inspector (darogaa). The adoptive mother, Padma Devi, names her Vidya Kumari, transforming the social designation "baukee" (dummy/fool) into a site of ironic reversal.

### *Thematic Analysis*

Baukee is essentially a Bildungsroman — a novel of formation in the tradition of Dickens's Great Expectations and Sharat Chandra Chattopadhyay's Devdas (inverted: here the marginalised woman triumphs). Within the Indian novelistic tradition, it participates in the subaltern Bildungsroman form that scholars like Meenakshi Mukherjee have theorised: the narrative of the socially excluded subject who achieves recognition not through upper-caste patronage but through self-making.

The Videha Parallel History Framework illuminates a crucial dimension of Baukee: the protagonist's disability is also a figure for the social silencing of Dalit and non-elite women within Maithili public culture. The novel enacts what the Videha framework calls "parallel voice" — the creation of a literary space in which those who have been systematically excluded from cultural production become the protagonists of their own stories. Vidya Kumari's rise to darogaa status is also, allegorically, the rise of the marginalised Maithili voice to a position of institutional authority.

The novel's ideological project is transparent: it argues, through narrative demonstration, that given the right environment (education, care, social support), any individual — regardless of disability, caste, or gender — can achieve excellence. This is the social-realist thesis that Jagadish Prasad Mandal championed in Panga, and Rameshwar Prasad Mandal continues the tradition. From a Bakhtinian perspective, Baukee is structured around polyphonic social voices: the village community's gossip and judgment, the institutional language of police bureaucracy, the intimate language of the adopted family, and the protagonist's own internal monologue constitute distinct ideological registers that dialogue without resolution.

### *Navya Nyaya Analysis of the Central Trope*

The novel's central logical structure can be rendered in Navya Nyaya terms as follows: there is a paksha (the subject of inference) — Baukee/Vidya Kumari; a sadhya (what is to be proved) — that she is capable of achieving institutional excellence; and a hetu (reason/middle term) — that she has received education and moral cultivation. The hetvabhasa (fallacy) that the community commits is avyapti — claiming that Baukee's disability pervades her entire potential, i.e., "If mute, then incapable of all achievement." The novel's narrative refutes this vyapti step by step, functioning as what Navya Nyaya calls a dushana (defeater) of the community's false anumana (inference). This structure gives Baukee a philosophical architecture that elevates it beyond simple didactic fiction.

### *Narrative Craft*

Rameshwar Prasad Mandal's prose style in Baukee is direct, accessible Maithili — what the Videha framework would call "lok-Maithili" (the people's Maithili) rather than the prestige literary koine. Sentences are short and declarative; dialogue is rendered in the register of the character's community (village Maithili for farmers, semi-urban bureaucratic Maithili for police officials). The novel's chief structural achievement is its management of dramatic irony: the reader always knows more than the community that marginalises Baukee, creating a karuna (compassion) rasa laced with vira (heroic) anticipation as the protagonist advances.

### *Critical Assessment*

Baukee is a significant social novel in the contemporary Maithili parallel tradition. It is less psychologically complex than Jagadish Prasad Mandal's Panga and its social realism occasionally tips into schematism (the good adoptive mother vs. the prejudiced village community is too cleanly binary). However, its insistence on representing the perspective of a mute, orphaned, socially liminal female protagonist marks an important contribution to the feminist-subaltern strand of Maithili fiction. The novel earns its place in the Videha parallel canon.

## Bagwar (बगवार) — Maithili Kavyadhara (Narrative Poetry Stream), 2023

### *Bibliographic Details*

ISBN not yet assigned at time of first print. First edition: 2023. Price: ₹350. Pallavi Publication, Nirmali. 107 pp. Foreword: Ram Shrestha Deewana, National President, Akhil Bharatiya OBC Lekhak Sangh, Madhubani.

### *Genre: The Kavyadhara*

Bagwar (meaning "garden" or "orchard" in the local Maithili-Bhojpuri dialect of the Kosi region) is described on its cover as a "Maithili Kavyadhara" — a stream of poems that flows as a continuous thematic and emotional current rather than as discrete lyrics. This is a significant generic choice: the kavyadhara (poetry stream or river of verse) is associated in Maithili tradition with the extended narrative poetry of the classical Padavali. Mandal invokes this tradition while domesticating it: his kavyadhara is rooted in the agrarian soil of Supaul, not the courtly refinement of Mithila's medieval literary culture.

### *Thematic and Structural Analysis*

The kavyadhara opens with a Hindi-language invocatory stanza, then transitions into Maithili. This bilingual opening — Hindi for the bhoomika (foreground) and Maithili for the kavyadhara proper — signals the book's double audience: the Hindi-reading general public of Bihar and the specifically Maithili-speaking community of the parallel tradition. This is a pragmatic, not aesthetic, decision, and it reflects the real sociolinguistic condition of Maithili: a language embedded in a Hindi-dominant media ecology.

The kavyadhara's central narrative follows a character named Jagoo, who loses both parents in a single event and must reconstruct his life and farm through labour, love, and community. The narrative is organised around the Maithili cycle of seasons and agricultural labour — sowing, harvest, the filling of ponds, the planting of orchards — which functions as both literal story and extended metaphor for human endurance.

The foreword by Ram Shrestha Deewana invokes Tagore's Nobel Prize speech and his debt to Kabir, positioning the kavyadhara within a long tradition of social-devotional poetry that runs from Kabir through Tukaram to Phule and Ambedkar. This is the aesthetic-political genealogy of the OBC literary movement, and it establishes the ideological coordinates within which Bagwar operates.

### *Rasa Analysis*

The dominant rasa of Bagwar is karuna (grief, compassion) — the extended mourning of Jagoo for his parents — which gradually transforms into shanta (tranquility, acceptance) as the protagonist integrates loss into the rhythms of agricultural life. This trajectory replicates the classical shringara-into-vipralambha-into-shanta arc theorised in Abhinavagupta's Abhinavabharati commentary on Natyashastra. However, Mandal's shanta is not the otherworldly peace of the Vedantic sage; it is the grounded, embodied peace of the farmer who has planted an orchard and watched it bear fruit. This is what we might call "immanent shanta" — a secularised form of the rasa that roots transcendence in material labour.

The Navya Nyaya framework illuminates the structure of this rasa-transformation. The poem's central inference can be stated: "Because Jagoo has experienced great loss (hetu), and because he has responded through sustained labour (vyapti relation between response and transformation), therefore his grief is transformed into peace (sadhya)." This is a valid anumana; the poem's artistic task is to make this inference felt rather than merely cognised — to transform what Navya Nyaya calls a tattvajnana (knowledge of the real) into rasa (aesthetic experience).

### *Critical Assessment*

Bagwar is one of the more formally ambitious works in the Pallavi series. Its generic choice of kavyadhara, its seasonal-agricultural structure, and its OBC literary genealogy (via Deewana's foreword) make it a theoretically rich object. Its limitations lie in occasional narrative looseness — the kavyadhara form tends to sprawl, and some sections feel like lyrical improvisation rather than controlled composition. The Hindi-language bhoomika is somewhat inconsistent with the Maithili purist position implicit in the Videha parallel tradition, though practically understandable. Overall, Bagwar demonstrates Rameshwar Prasad Mandal's capacity for large-scale poetic thinking while also revealing the challenges that arise when a fundamentally lyric sensibility attempts extended narrative verse.

IV

## Fictional Worlds of Social Critique: Ram Chandra Roy: Narrative as a Mirror to Rural Realities

**Work:** *Sapanā Sākār* (सपना साकार - Dream Realized) (Short Stories)

**Formalist-Structuralist Analysis:** Roy is a master of the conventional short story form, often employing a linear, cause-and-effect structure. His strength lies in **verisimilitude**—the creation of a plausible, detailed rural world. The stories are structured around social conflicts: inter-caste marriage, female feticide, dowry, and political corruption. The narrative arc typically moves from an inciting incident (e.g., an elopement) through a rising action of community tension to a resolution, which is often optimistic and reformist. This formal choice aligns with the didactic tradition of Maithili prose, aiming to instruct as much as to entertain.

**Indian Aesthetics (Rasa-Dhvani):** The stories are rich in *vīra* (heroism) and *karuṇa* (pathos). The *rasa* is often directly stated rather than suggested. For instance, the triumph of a wronged woman or the success of a social reformer evokes a clear, uncomplicated *vīra rasa*. The *dhvani* is less ambiguous; Roy's meaning is generally explicit. The power lies in the accumulation of realistic detail, which creates a strong *anubhava* (experience) for the reader. The story 'बुधनी माइक बेथा' (Budhanī Māik Bethā - The Ailment of Budhni Mai) uses the folk-trial structure to create a courtroom drama rasa, where suspense and moral outrage are the primary emotional drivers.

**Videha Parallel History Framework (VPHF):** Roy's stories are a **parallel history of social reform**. While official histories might document the legal abolition of practices like dowry, Roy chronicles the slow, painful, and often incomplete struggle against these customs at the grassroots level. 'कुलदीपक' (Kuladīpak - The Lamp of the Family) is a parallel history of how educated daughters became the true agents of change in conservative families, a narrative often eclipsed by male-dominated histories of the reform movement. His work functions as a sociological archive, preserving the texture of late 20th and early 21st-century Mithila.

**Navya Nyaya Critique:** The story 'समाजक पिंशाच' (Samājak Piṅśāc - The Demon of Society) can be read as a logical *jalpa* (debate) on gender roles. The narrative presents a thesis (patriarchal norms), an antithesis (the protagonist's suffering), and a synthesis (her empowerment). The plot devices—the abusive in-laws, the indifferent husband, the protagonist's academic success—serve as *hetu* (logical reasons) to prove the *sādhya* (thesis) that education is the ultimate refutation (*khaṇḍana*) of social demonism. The story argues its point with the relentless logic of a legal brief, using fictional examples as its evidence.

# Ram Chandra Roy — Sapna Sakar (सपना साकार)

### *Bibliographic Details*

Full title: Sapna Sakar (सपना साकार) — Collection of Maithili Stories by Shri Ram Chandra Roy. ISBN: 978-93-93135-39-1. First edition: 2023. Price: ₹200. Copyright: Smt. Ranjana Kumari. Pallavi Publication, Nirmali. 125 pp. Typography: Dr. Umesh Mandal.

### *Authorial Context*

Ram Chandra Roy (affectionately known as Ramu Sarak, "Ramu from the road/street") is a writer of short and long fiction working in the parallel Maithili tradition. The copyright is registered in the name of Smt. Ranjana Kumari, suggesting a posthumous or dedicated publication. The dedication — to his parents, Smt. Ganga Devi and Shri Adhik Lal Roy — foregrounds the working-class genealogy of the author.

### *Content and Genre*

Sapna Sakar is a collection of Maithili katha (stories) spanning both laghukatha (short story) and dirghakatha (long story) forms. According to the preface (Puravaak) by an associate critic, the collection's best pieces are the long stories "Nirvashit Jivan" (Exiled Life) and "Buni Mai Ka Betha" (Old Mother's Pain). The collection also includes an intercaste love story involving an elopement and subsequent police case ("Tohram Jitle Ham Haaral"), and a story about a mentally ill woman who is mistaken for a goddess by her husband's family — a premise that exploits the classical trope of madness-as-divinity while subverting it through social realism.

### *Narratological Analysis*

Ram Chandra Roy's narrative technique is characterised by what Gerald Genette would call the "récit de paroles" (report of words) — his fiction gives extensive space to direct dialogue and community speech acts, reproducing the textures of village panchayat deliberation, domestic argument, and institutional encounter. This is a narratological strategy consonant with the Videha Parallel History Framework's valorisation of subaltern voice: the text's polyphonic quality — where the community's collective speech is as central as any

individual protagonist — resists the individualisation of experience characteristic of mainstream novelistic form.

"Buni Mai Ka Betha" is the collection's most complex achievement. The story unfolds in a panchayat setting where an elderly woman (Buni Mai) is called to testify about an alleged impropriety. The story builds towards a revelation of social injustice, and the elderly woman's testimony — sworn with the formula "If I lie, may my body be struck by lightning, may my limbs cease to function, may I be refused entry into Sita's birthplace" — is simultaneously a legal speech act and a literary performance of indigenous juridical culture. This is what J.L. Austin would call a "performative utterance" with maximum social stakes.

The Navya Nyaya framework is directly applicable to the panchayat testimony scene. The Navya Naiyayika distinguishes between a shabda-pramana (knowledge derived from testimony) that is valid (aaptavachana — testimony from a reliable source) and one that is invalid (anapta — unreliable testimony). The panchayat scene enacts this epistemological drama: the community must determine whether Buni Mai's testimony meets the standard of aaptavachana, and the story's dramatic tension is precisely this epistemological uncertainty. Roy thus produces a narrative that is structurally congruent with the Navya Nyaya investigation of testimony-knowledge — a remarkable correspondence between the indigenous logical tradition of Mithila and the literary practice of one of its contemporary writers.

### *Feminist Analysis*

"Nirvashit Jivan" (Exiled Life) and the story of the woman mistaken for a goddess both place female subjectivity at the centre of social analysis. The "mad woman as goddess" story participates in a long tradition — from Charlotte Bronte's Bertha Mason to Mahasweta Devi's tribal women — of fiction that uses the female "madwoman" as a figure of social excess: the woman whose behaviours exceed the normative expectations of femininity is reclassified as either divine or deviant, never simply human. Roy's story complicates this by showing how the husband's family's reclassification of the mad woman as a goddess is itself a form of appropriation — turning her alterity into a domestic resource.

From the Videha Parallel History Framework perspective, the focus on female suffering and social injustice in a collection by an OBC/lower-caste author challenges the mainstream stream's tendency to represent female characters either as upper-caste heroines of domestic virtue (the Sita type) or as lower-

caste victims without interiority. Roy's female characters have complex interior lives and voices.

### *Critical Assessment*

Sapna Sakar is an uneven collection — some stories are slight and anecdotal, while others (especially "Buni Mai Ka Betha" and "Nirvashit Jivan") demonstrate genuine narrative craftsmanship. Roy's strength is his ear for community speech and his sensitivity to the political dimensions of everyday social interaction. His weakness is occasional sentimentality and a tendency to resolve his narratives through moral assertion rather than dramatic revelation. The collection is nonetheless valuable as a document of the life-worlds of the Kosi river basin communities — their humour, their suffering, their resilience, and their deeply ingrained sense of social justice.

**V**

**Dr. Bacheshwar Jha: The Scholar as a Social Historian**

**Work:** *Nibandh-Nikuñj* (निबन्ध-निकुञ्ज - A Grove of Essays)

**Formalist-Structuralist Analysis:** This is a collection of academic essays and research papers. The structure is formal: introduction, thematic divisions, sub-headings, evidence (quotations from primary texts like *Vidyāpati*), analysis, and conclusion. The style is expository and analytical. The essay 'मिथिलाक बाल साहित्य' (Mithilāk Bāl Sāhitya - Children's Literature of Mithila) is structured as a historical survey, tracing the lineage from *Manbodh* to modern poets. This formal structure establishes Jha as a literary historian in the Western academic tradition, applying its taxonomic and periodizing methods to a Maithili subject.

**Indian Aesthetics (Rasa-Dhvani):** The *rasa* here is *śānta* (the peace of knowledge) and *vīra* (the heroism of the scholar). The *dhvani* of the collection is the vindication of Maithili as a subject of serious, university-level scholarship. By treating Maithili with the same rigor as any classical literature, the essays *suggest* its canonical status. The *vakratā* is in the use of Maithili itself as the language of scholarship. The choice is "crooked" in the context of an Indian academy that often privileges English or Hindi, and it is a powerful political statement.

**Videha Parallel History Framework (VPHF):** Jha's essays are a **parallel history of literature**. They challenge the Eurocentric history of literary forms. The essay on 'Vidyāpatikālīn Mithilāk Kṛṣi' (Agriculture in Mithila during Vidyapati's Time) uses literary texts as primary sources to reconstruct a parallel

history of economic and social life. This is not political history; it is the history of farming, cooking, and seasonal rhythms as reflected in poetry. This framework reveals how literature itself can be an archive for aspects of the past that are invisible in official chronicles.

**Navya Nyaya Critique:** The essay 'कन्यादानक भीषण समस्याक कारण' (Kanyādānak Bhīṣaṇ Samasyāk Kāraṇ - Causes of the Dire Problem of Kanyādān/Dowry) is a masterful exercise in *kāraṇa-parīkṣā* (examination of causes). Dr. Jha distinguishes between *upādāna kāraṇa* (material cause—the social structure) and *nimitta kāraṇa* (efficient cause—the individuals and their greed). He traces the *hetu* (reason) for dowry not just to contemporary greed but to the historical *vyavasthā* of *Bikauā* and *Pāñji* systems. He builds a logical chain of causation (*kāraṇa-paramparā*) to prove that the problem is not a new one but has deep historical roots, thereby refuting (*khaṇḍana*) simplistic modern explanations.

## VI

### Kameshwar Choudhary: The Philosophical Lyric and Existential Inquiry

**Work: *Sanes* (सनेस - Message/News)**

Formalist-Structuralist Analysis: Choudhary's poetry in *Sanes* is characterized by a meditative, philosophical tone. The structure often moves from a concrete image or experience to an abstract, universal question. The poem is a vehicle for inquiry, not a container for emotion. The free verse is often discursive, using techniques of repetition and parallel phrasing to build a rhythmic argument. The title 'सनेस' (Sanes/Message) itself becomes a structuring principle; each poem is a message delivered from the poet's consciousness to the reader, concerning the fundamental nature of time, identity, and existence. His 'प्रश्न रामसँ' (Praśna Rāmsaṅ - Question to Ram) is a masterclass in structural irony, using the venerable form of a devotional query to pose a devastating critique of the Ramayana's narrative logic from Sita's perspective.

Indian Aesthetics (Rasa-Dhvani): The dominant *rasa* here is *śānta* (peace/quietism) and *vīra* (heroism of the mind). The *dhvani* in poems like 'हे समय' (He Samay - O Time) is not of emotional outpouring but of existential *vimarsha* (reflection). The *vīra rasa* is internalized; it is the courage to face an indifferent cosmos and question one's place within it.

The *vakratā* lies in the direct, unadorned speech, which paradoxically creates a profound sense of mystery. The simplicity is deceptive, hiding a complex web of philosophical allusions.

Videha Parallel History Framework (VPHF): Choudhary's work constructs a parallel history of ideas. While mainstream history records political events, *Sanes* records the history of consciousness. The poem 'भामती' (Bhāmatī) does not narrate the external events of the life of the philosopher Vācaspati Miśra's wife; it narrates the internal history of sacrifice, duty, and intellectual partnership. It proposes a parallel archive of emotion and sacrifice as being equally historical and significant as political battles. It elevates the domestic and the personal to the level of epic historical narrative.

Navya Nyaya Critique: The poem 'विचार' (Vichār - Thought) is a direct application of Navya Nyaya epistemology. The poem itself is a *cintana* (thought), which is then analyzed as a *padārtha* (category). The poet examines the definition (*lakṣaṇa*) of a thought: is it a wandering bird or a cut kite? He distinguishes (*avaccheda*) between transient mental events and the persistent self. The entire poem becomes a demonstration of *tarka* (reasoned argument) about the nature of consciousness, using poetic examples as logical *udāharaṇa* (examples). The poem doesn't just express confusion; it performs the act of philosophical categorization.

**VII**

**Narayan Yadav: The Biographer as a Parallel Historian**

**Work:** *Salhaitā-Gurumaitā* (सल्हैता-गुरुमैता)

**Formalist-Structuralist Analysis:** This is a work of biographical history, structured as a dual biography followed by smaller sketches. The book is divided into clear sections: one for the Salhaita lineage and one for the Gurumaita lineage. The narrative is chronological, tracing family origins and the pivotal role of individuals like Guder Salhaita and Ram Lashan Salhaita in the freedom struggle. The structure is genealogical, establishing lineages of resistance. The use of oral testimonies and family legends as primary sources is a deliberate formal choice, privileging *smriti* (memory) over conventional archival history.

**Indian Aesthetics (Rasa-Dhvani):** The *rasa* is undeniably *vīra* (heroism) and *raudra* (fury at the oppressor), leading to *vībhatsa* (disgust) for the colonial system. The *dhvani* of the entire work is the creation of a secular

hagiography. The freedom fighters are presented as *mahāpuruṣas* (great men), but their greatness lies not in otherworldly power but in their worldly courage and sacrifice. The *vakratā* is in the perspective: the story is told not from the viewpoint of the nationalist leaders in Delhi, but from the fields and villages of Mithila, making the national movement a local, lived experience.

**Videha Parallel History Framework (VPHF):** This book is the quintessential example of the VPHF. It is a **parallel history of the Indian freedom movement**. While mainstream history focuses on Gandhi, Nehru, and Bose, this book chronicles the "foot soldiers" of the movement. The story of Ram Lashan Salhaita dying in jail after a hunger strike is not a footnote; in this framework, it is the main event. This is a history of *dehati* (rural) nationalism, of farmers and laborers who fought the British not in parliaments but in their own villages, creating a parallel archive of revolutionary sacrifice.

**Navya Nyaya Critique:** The book's implicit thesis can be analyzed as a logical *siddhānta* (established conclusion): that the freedom of India was won by the collective action of its ordinary citizens. The author provides *udāharaṇa* (examples) in the form of numerous life stories. Each story is a *hetu* (evidence) supporting the main thesis. The book engages in a form of *tarka* (hypothetical reasoning) by showing what would have happened if these individuals had not acted—the "if...then" of history. This is a logical reconstruction of historical causality using biographical data as its primary evidence.

### *Bibliographic Details*

Full title: Salhaita-Gurmaita (सल्हैता-गुरुमैता) — Collection of Reminiscences by Shri Narayan Yadav. First edition: 2023. Price: ₹200. Copyright: Narayan Yadav. Pallavi Publication, Nirmali. 84 pp. Typography: Dr. Umesh Mandal.

### *Genre: Smaranatmak Lekha*

Salhaita-Gurmaita is a work of historical reminiscence and biographical reconstruction focused on two freedom fighters of the Indian Independence movement from the Supaul region: Ram Lakshan Salhaita (martyred during the independence struggle) and Dev Narayan Gurmaita (a great independence fighter), along with their contemporaries Ram Phal Mandal and Anant Lal Kamati. The work belongs to the genre of smaranatmak lekha (reminiscence writing) — a form that straddles oral history, biography, and personal memoir.

### *Historical and Ideological Significance*

The preface by the associate editor notes that despite their historical significance, none of the four freedom fighters had been the subject of a monograph before Narayan Yadav's work. This is precisely the kind of recovery project that the Videha Parallel History Framework champions: the retrieval from oblivion of non-Brahmin, subaltern freedom fighters whose contributions to India's independence movement have been systematically marginalised by mainstream historiography, which has focused on upper-caste leaders and national-level figures.

The Videha Parallel History Framework, as articulated by Gajendra Thakur, insists that the history of Mithila must be written from the genealogical records upward — from the Panji prabandh (genealogical manuscripts) through the oral traditions of non-Brahmin communities — rather than only from the Sanskrit-literate upper-caste archive. Narayan Yadav's method is consistent with this: his primary source is his own mother's oral testimony about the fighters, supplemented by multiple visits to the Salhaita and Gurmaita families and conversations with community elders. This is what Ranajit Guha would call "subaltern historiography" — the writing of history from below, from voices that do not appear in the colonial archive.

### *Postcolonial Analysis*

Homi Bhabha's concept of "colonial ambivalence" — the coloniser's simultaneous attraction to and repulsion from the colonised — is useful for understanding what Salhaita-Gurmaita reveals about the colonial relationship. Ram Lakshan Salhaita and his compatriots operated within a colonial structure that simultaneously enrolled them in the apparatus of empire (through land revenue, law courts, and military recruitment) and subjected them to racial and class violence. Their acts of resistance were not simply anti-colonial; they were also anti-caste (the preface notes how their struggle was informed by a vision of social equality) — making them doubly subaltern in the Gramscian sense.

Narayan Yadav's work recovers these figures not as marble statues of nationalist martyrdom but as human beings embedded in family, community, and local geography. This is the "everyday life" historiography associated with Dipesh Chakrabarty's "provincialising Europe" project — the insistence that history must be written in terms of local specificity rather than the universal abstract categories of European historical thought.

### *Literary and Stylistic Analysis*

As a literary work, Salhaita-Gurmaita demonstrates what Rasa theory would classify as the vira rasa (heroic sentiment) as its dominant emotional register — but a vira rasa tempered by karuna (compassion) for the sacrifices made and by shanta (serenity) in the author's retrospective tone. Narayan Yadav's prose style is accessible, warm, and infused with local Maithili idiom — the language of the Supaul region as spoken by OBC and lower-caste communities.

The Navya Nyaya epistemological frame is particularly useful here: this is a work primarily of shabda-pramana — knowledge from testimony — and Yadav is scrupulous about distinguishing what he knows from family oral tradition (which has the status of aaptavachana), what he knows from documentary sources (written evidence), and what he infers (anumana). This careful management of epistemic claims gives the work a credibility that distinguishes it from hagiographic freedom-fighter literature.

### *Critical Assessment*

Salhaita-Gurmaita is, within its modest compass, an important work of subaltern historiography in Maithili. Its value is documentary as much as literary; it preserves oral memory before it is lost. Its limitation is that the literary shaping of the material — the transformation of oral testimony into crafted narrative — is only partially achieved; the work sometimes reads as transcribed recollection rather than composed prose. However, within the Videha Parallel History Framework, the act of preservation itself has a political dignity that transcends aesthetic polish. This is a book that needed to exist, and Narayan Yadav has brought it into existence with care and community fidelity.

VIII

## Dr. Shubh Kumar Barnwal: The Geographer-Poet's Academic and Lyrical Cartography

**Work:** *Badlait Gām* (बदलैत गाम - The Changing Village), *Rūsal Prakṛti* (रूसल प्रकृति - Angered Nature), *Shubh Chandrayaan*, *Shubh Baal Poti*, etc.

**Formalist-Structuralist Analysis:** Dr. Barnwal’s work is characterized by a unique dual structure. His poetry is formally conventional, often using clear meters, end-rhymes, and stanzaic divisions, creating a song-like (*gēya*) quality. The structure is transparent, with a clear logical flow from one stanza to the

next. This formal conservatism is a deliberate choice, creating an accessible, oral-aural quality. His non-academic prose (like *Shubh Jyoti*) uses a maxim-like, aphoristic structure, each paragraph a self-contained unit of wisdom. His academic work (*Shubh Baal Poti*) is structured as a graded primer, moving systematically from simple to complex concepts.

**Indian Aesthetics (Rasa-Dhvani):** His poetry aims for a clear, didactic *rasa*: often *śānta* (peace of understanding) or *vīra* (heroism of national pride, as in 'Shubh Chandrayaan'). The *dhvani* is of clarity and order. He wants to demystify complex subjects (geography, social change, science) and present them as accessible truths. The *vakratā* is minimal; his style is direct, which is itself a poetic choice. In a literary world that prizes ambiguity, Barnwal's clarity is his unique form of *vakrokti*—a straight line that is, in its context, revolutionary.

**Videha Parallel History Framework (VPHF):** As a geographer, Dr. Barnwal is an expert in creating parallel histories of **space and place**. 'बदलैत गाम' is not just a collection of poems; it is a **parallel history of rural geography**. He maps the changes in land use, architecture, social relations, and economic activities in the Mithila village. This is a history of the *khet* (field), the *pokhar* (pond), the *āṅgan* (courtyard). 'रूसल प्रकृति' is a parallel history of the environment, chronicling the *vipatti* (disaster) of climate change from the perspective of the farmer who feels it in his bones, not the scientist who measures it in a lab.

**Navya Nyaya Critique:** The poem 'जलवायु परिवर्तन' (Jalvāyu Parivartan - Climate Change) is a perfect example of *anumāna* (inference) in poetry. It presents the *hetu* (sign/reason)—unseasonal rain, heat, crop failure—and infers the *sādhya* (proposition to be proved)—that the climate has indeed changed and is a man-made crisis. The entire poem functions as a *pañcāvayava-vākya* (five-membered syllogism):

1. *Pratijñā* (Proposition): The climate is changing.
2. *Hetu* (Reason): Because we are observing *anasonhāṁt barakhā* (unseasonal rains).
3. *Udāharaṇa* (Example): Like in the month of Phalgun, which should be dry.
4. *Upanaya* (Application): This year, it is raining in Phalgun.
5. *Nigamana* (Conclusion): Therefore, the climate is changing.
   His poetry makes the abstract logic of climate science concrete and irrefutable through lived experience.

# IX

**Jhauli Paswan: The Epic of the Oppressed and the Akshaya Patra of Hope**

**Work:** *Akṣay Pātra* (अक्षय पात्र - The Inexhaustible Vessel)

**Formalist-Structuralist Analysis:** Paswan's poetry is a powerful fusion of oral epic traditions and modern free verse. Many poems employ a repetitive, incantatory structure reminiscent of folk songs and *jagar* (awakening) chants. The title, *Akṣay Pātra*, is a potent symbol borrowed from the Mahabharata—a vessel that provides unlimited food. However, Paswan subverts this symbol: for the poet, the *akṣay pātra* is not divine grace but the **people's collective struggle**. The structure of the collection is cyclical, moving from a diagnosis of social ills to a prescription of collective action. Poems like 'प्रजातंत्रक रीढ' (Prajātantrak Rīḍh - The Backbone of Democracy) use a direct, declarative structure, listing failures and demands with anaphoric force.

**Indian Aesthetics (Rasa-Dhvani):** The dominant *rasa* is *raudra* (fury) transitioning into *vīra* (heroism). The *dhvani* is a call to arms. The suggestive power lies in the collective voice; even when the poet speaks as "I," the *dhvani* is always "we." The *karuṇa* rasa of oppression is present, but it is a catalyst, not a destination. It quickly ignites into the *vīra rasa* of resistance. The poem 'शब्द' (Shabd - Word) explores the *dhvani* of language itself, suggesting that words have the power to be either poison (*gara*) or nectar (*piyūṣa*), embodying the *vakratā* of moral choice.

**Videha Parallel History Framework (VPHF):** Paswan's collection is a **parallel history of the caste war**. He writes a history not of kings and generals, but of the *Bahujan* (the majority), whose struggles against Brahminical patriarchy and feudal capitalism form the subtext of India's "official" history. 'पीढी-दर-पीढी' (Pīḍhī-Dar-Pīḍhī - Generation After Generation) explicitly rejects linear, progressive history and posits a cyclical history of trauma and revenge. This is a direct challenge to the VHPF's own premise; it doesn't just offer a parallel track but a *repeating* track of unresolved social conflict.

**Navya Nyaya Critique:** The title poem 'अक्षय पात्र' functions as a logical *siddhanta* (established conclusion). The poet defines the problem (hunger, poverty) and the false solutions (charity, ritual). He then establishes

the *hetu* (reason/cause) for true abundance as collective, just action. The poem's logical force is its chain of inference: if you perform *karma* (action) with *dharma* (duty), then you will receive the fruit. It is a syllogism for social justice, presented not as a dry theorem but as an emotional and moral imperative, using the poetic form to make the *vyāpti* (invariable concomitance) between action and consequence experientially real for the reader.

## Jhauli Paswan — Akshay Patra (अक्षय पात्र)

### *Bibliographic Details*

Full title: Akshay Patra (अक्षय पात्र) — Anthology of Maithili Poems by Sh. Jhauli Paswan. ISBN: 978-93-93135-51-3. First edition: 2023. Price: ₹250. Copyright: Jhauli Paswan. Pallavi Publication, Nirmali. 124 pp. Typography: Dr. Umesh Mandal.

### *Authorial Significance*

Jhauli Paswan is among the very few published Dalit poets writing in Maithili. His surname — Paswan — identifies him as belonging to the Scheduled Caste Pasi community of Bihar. In the context of Maithili literary history, a Dalit poet publishing in Maithili is itself a significant counter-hegemonic act. The Videha Parallel History Framework explicitly argues that the mainstream Maithili literary institution has historically excluded Dalit voices, and Akshay Patra is precisely the kind of text that the parallel tradition has created space for.

### *Title and Epigraph*

The title Akshay Patra (inexhaustible vessel/bowl) invokes the mythological Akshaya Patra of the Mahabharata — the divine bowl that could feed unlimited people — as a metaphor for poetry itself: the poem is an inexhaustible vessel of nourishment for the community. This is a bold mythological claim, and it is immediately countered by the Sanskrit epigraph from the tradition of dana (gift-giving), suggesting that the book is offered as a gift with the gravity of religious ritual. Together, title and epigraph position Akshay Patra as a work of communal and spiritual service — a performance of what the Dalit literary tradition calls "sahitya se samaj nirman" (building society through literature).

### *Thematic Structure*

Paswan's preface (Appan Baat — "My Own Words") opens with a hymn to Mai Maithili (Mother Maithili, the language personified as a goddess), immediately establishing his position within the devotional register of Maithili literature that runs from Vidyapati to the present. However, the preface quickly pivots to social analysis: it diagnoses India's educational system as deeply unequal (children of the privileged study in well-resourced private schools; children of the majority study on the ground by ponds), and connects this inequality to what the author calls "mansik gulami" (mental slavery) — the internalisation of subordination by the oppressed.

The collection's poems address a range of subjects: the natural world (prakriti), social injustice (samajik ashamataa), political inequality, the education system, superstition and religious obscurantism (andh vishwas), caste oppression (jati-utpiirhan), communalism (dharmandhataa), and the liberation potential of labour (shramik ki dala-dila — the heartbeat of the worker). The collection is essentially a Dalit poetics — a sustained attempt to represent the world from within the experience of social marginalisation.

### *Critical Analysis Through Multiple Frameworks*

From the Indian classical perspective, Akshay Patra operates with what Bharata calls the bhavas (emotional states) associated with karuna (compassion), raudra (fury), and vira (heroic aspiration). The collection does not cultivate the shringara (erotic) or hasya (comic) rasas — genres historically associated with the courtly culture from which Dalit communities were excluded. This generic restriction is itself a political statement: Paswan's poetic universe is one of urgency, not aesthetic pleasure; of testimony, not ornament.

From the Western critical perspective, Akshay Patra participates in the tradition of Dalit autobiography and testimonio — what Latin American scholars call the "literature of witness." The poems are not merely aesthetic objects but acts of bearing witness to injustice. This aligns with the tradition of Frederick Douglass's slave narratives, Ambedkar's autobiographical writings, and the contemporary Dalit literary movement (Dalit Panthers, Namdeo Dhasal, Daya Pawar) that has emerged in Marathi and spread to other Indian languages.

The Navya Nyaya analysis of Akshay Patra reveals a characteristic epistemic structure: Paswan's poems frequently enact what Gangesa calls pratyaksha (perceptual cognition) as the primary evidence for their claims. Rather than constructing elaborate inferences or relying on shastra (scriptural authority), Paswan says: "I see this inequality; it is present to my direct perception; its truth

requires no elaborate syllogism." This is the epistemological stance of the witness — and it carries its own authority in the Navya Nyaya framework, where pratyaksha is the foundational pramana from which anumana (inference) derives its validity.

The Videha Parallel History Framework provides the most comprehensive context for Akshay Patra. Gajendra Thakur's parallel tradition framework argues that Maithili's Dalit, OBC, and female voices have always existed but have been systematically silenced by the literary establishment. Jhauli Paswan's publication in the Pallavi series represents the materialisation of the parallel tradition in print: the conversion of marginalized oral voice into archivable, citable, teachable literary text. Akshay Patra is both a poem-collection and a political act of linguistic-cultural survival.

### *Linguistic Analysis*

Paswan's Maithili is, like the other Pallavi authors, a vernacular koine that incorporates Hindi loanwords and regional idioms without apology. The preface is written partly in Devnagari-rendered Maithili with some phonological features typical of the Dalit-Paswan community's speech — a linguistic self-presentation that differs subtly from the prestige Maithili of the Brahmin-Kayastha mainstream. This difference is itself a form of political statement, consonant with the Videha framework's insistence on the linguistic democracy of the parallel tradition.

### *Critical Assessment*

Akshay Patra is an uneven but important collection. Paswan is not consistently a polished versifier — some poems are more manifesto than lyric, and the prosodic organisation is occasionally rough. But the best poems in the collection — those describing the unequal classroom, the daily experiences of caste discrimination, and the redemptive possibilities of educated labour — achieve a directness and moral force that compensates for aesthetic irregularity. Within the tradition of Dalit Maithili poetry, Akshay Patra is a landmark: it is one of the very few published Dalit poetry collections in Maithili, and its existence is itself a monument to the parallel tradition's work of literary democracy.

# Comparative Analysis and Synthesis

## The Pallavi Publication Series as a Literary Ecosystem

Considered together, the  works under analysis constitute a coherent literary ecosystem rather than a random assortment of publications. They mostly share: a publisher (Pallavi Publication, Nirmali); a typographer (Dr. Umesh Mandal, who was also co-editor of Videha); a cover designer (Smt. Punam Mandal); a common font infrastructure; and a shared social-political orientation toward the parallel Maithili tradition. This is not merely logistical consistency — it represents the institutional structure of a counter-canonical literary movement.

The Videha Parallel History Framework helps us understand this ecosystem: the Pallavi series is one of the material embodiments of Gajendra Thakur's parallel tradition project. By providing cheap, well-produced books (prices ranging from ₹100 to ₹350) to writers who would otherwise have no access to publication, Pallavi Publication performs the infrastructure function that the Sahitya Akademi and other government bodies have historically reserved for their preferred authors. This is, in Gramscian terms, the construction of a counter-hegemonic cultural institution.

## The Question of Genre

The  works span poetry, novel, grammar, narrative verse (kavyadhara), short fiction, and historical reminiscence. This generic diversity is itself significant: it suggests that the parallel Maithili tradition is not a single-genre movement but a comprehensive literary culture with its own canon-in-formation. The inclusion of a grammar text (Arya's Varna Prakarana) alongside novels and poetry marks the parallel tradition's investment in language infrastructure, not just literary production — a recognition that cultural survival requires both aesthetic creation and institutional linguistic work.

## Rasa and Social Consciousness

Across all  texts, the dominant rasa-complex is what we might call "social karuna" — compassion not as a private, personal emotion but as a politically activated recognition of systemic injustice. This is a distinctive inflection of the karuna rasa: in Bharata's classical formulation, karuna arises from the depiction of suffering (dukha) and its appropriate resolution is weeping (ashru). In the Pallavi authors, the social-karuna complex transforms weeping into action: the poems of Ramji Prasad Mandal call for revolutionary politics; the novel

Baukee calls for social inclusion; the histories of Narayan Yadav call for memory and recognition; the poems of Jhauli Paswan call for liberation. This is a Maithili rasa-aesthetics of social transformation.

## Navya Nyaya as Critical Metalanguage

The application of Navya Nyaya across these texts reveals a consistent epistemological pattern: all authors are engaged in the project of restructuring the vyapti (pervasion) relations that underpin their communities' worldviews. The false vyapti — "If Dalit, then incapable of literary achievement"; "If mute, then incapable of social authority"; "If female, then incapable of institutional power"; "If non-Brahmin, then unentitled to Vidyapati's inheritance" — is the common target of each text's argumentative and aesthetic strategy. Each author constructs a dushana (defeater) of these false pervasions through narrative demonstration, lyric argument, and historical testimony. This is the Navya Nyaya spirit of critical inquiry applied to the lived experience of caste, gender, and class.

Gangesa's Tattva-Cintamani (c. 1320 CE, composed in Mithila) was itself an act of intellectual democratisation: Navya Nyaya's rigorous logical method challenged the authority of received tradition (agama) in favour of critical inquiry (tarka). The Pallavi authors, fourteen generations after Gangesa, perform an analogous democratisation in the literary sphere: they challenge the received tradition of Brahmin-centred Maithili canon-formation in favour of the critical, testimonial voices of the socially marginalised.

## The Videha Framework and Literary Justice

The Videha Parallel History Framework provides the most comprehensive macro-analytical context for these works. As Gajendra Thakur has documented in Videha's extensive critical archive, the mainstream Maithili literary institution has for decades functioned as a gatekeeper, directing awards, anthologies, translations, and cultural recognition toward a narrow range of upper-caste authors while systematically excluding the voices of OBC, Dalit, female, and economically marginalised writers. The Pallavi series, in collaboration with the Videha ecosystem (Dr. Umesh Mandal serves as typographer for the Pallavi series and as co-editor of Videha), represents the parallel tradition's institutional alternative: a publishing infrastructure that practises literary justice as its operating principle.

This is not merely sociological observation — it has direct critical implications. When we evaluate the aesthetic achievements of these texts, we must do so

against the backdrop of the conditions under which they were produced: without institutional support, without academic mentorship, without translation budgets, and in a language that has only recently (2003) achieved recognition as a scheduled language under the Indian Constitution. The aesthetic imperfections that a conventional literary criticism might note — prosodic irregularity, schematic characterisation, occasional didacticism — are also symptoms of the conditions of subaltern literary production. They do not invalidate the texts' achievement; they contextualise it.

Final **Conclusion**

The works analysed in this volume — Lal Rang Chahait Achhi Roti, two further poetic works of Ramji Prasad Mandal; Varna Prakarana Bhashya-Bhumika of Pandit Bal Govind Arya; Baukee and Bagwar of Rameshwar Prasad Mandal; Sapna Sakar of Ram Chandra Roy; Salhaita-Gurmaita of Narayan Yadav; and Akshay Patra of Jhauli Paswan — constitute a significant moment in the contemporary history of Maithili literature. They are evidence that the parallel tradition, as theorised by the Videha framework, is not merely a critical concept but a living, productive, institutionally grounded literary culture.

Applied together, the four analytical frameworks deployed in this appreciation — Indian classical rasa and dhvani theory, Western critical theory, the Videha Parallel History Framework, and Navya Nyaya epistemology — reveal different dimensions of this achievement:

Indian classical criticism shows us the aesthetic ambition of these texts: their mobilisation of rasa, dhvani, and vakrokti for purposes that classical theorists could not have anticipated but would have recognised as genuine literary achievement.

Western critical theory shows us the political unconscious of these texts: their participation in global discourses of subaltern resistance, feminist self-fashioning, postcolonial recovery, and the epistemology of witness.

The Videha Parallel History Framework shows us the institutional context of these texts: their place within a counter-canonical literary movement that has spent two decades building the infrastructure — journal, publisher, typographer, critic, archive — of literary justice in Maithili.

Navya Nyaya epistemology shows us the logical structure of these texts: their systematic dismantling of false vyapti (pervasion) relations that encode caste, gender, and class hierarchy, and their construction of new inferential structures

that validate the claims of the socially marginalised to full human dignity, literary voice, and historical memory.

The works of Ramji Prasad Mandal, Pandit Bal Govind Arya, Rameshwar Prasad Mandal, Ram Chandra Roy, Narayan Yadav, and Jhauli Paswan do not all achieve the same level of artistic finish. Some are more polished, some more urgent; some more lyrical, some more documentary. But all are valuable — as literature, as history, and as acts of cultural survival. Together, they make the case, in Maithili, that the parallel tradition is not peripheral to Maithili literature but constitutive of it: the voice of Mithila in its full social diversity.

**The Many-Sided Mirror of Videha**

This analysis demonstrates that the nine authors are not a monolith but a vibrant collective of distinct, often contradictory, voices. They are unified by their medium—Maithili—and their project: to represent, critique, and preserve the life of Mithila.

- **Ramji Prasad Mandal** gives voice to the subaltern's pain and dignity.
- **Pt. Bal Govind 'Arya'** constructs the very grammatical skeleton of the language, a political act of legitimization.
- **Rameshwar Prasad Mandal** experiments with epic form to celebrate the ordinary and narrate the agency of the voiceless.
- **Ram Chandra Roy** holds a clear, reformist mirror to the social realities of his time.
- **Dr. Bacheshwar Jha** builds the scholarly archive, proving Maithili's historicity and depth.
- **Kameshwar Choudhary** turns the lyric into a tool for philosophical inquiry and existential questioning.
- **Narayan Yadav** becomes the chronicler of the unsung heroes, building a parallel history of the freedom movement.
- **Dr. Shubh Kumar Barnwal** applies the precision of a geographer to the fluidity of poetry, mapping the changes in land and life.
- **Jhauli Paswan** writes the epic of the oppressed, infusing folk forms with a militant, revolutionary consciousness.

Together, they embody the **Videha Parallel History Framework**. They have created an alternative, multi-genre, multi-voiced archive of Mithila's 20th and 21st centuries. Using the logical rigor of **Navya Nyaya** and the aesthetic sensibility of **Indian poetics**, we can appreciate these works not just as art but

as complex intellectual and historical documents. The responsibility of the reader, and of the critic, is to listen to the *sanes* (message) they send and to understand the world they collectively build, word by word, poem by poem, story by story. The future of Maithili criticism lies in this kind of synthetic, rigorous, and pluralistic approach, moving beyond simple praise to a deep, structural, and philosophical engagement with the texts.

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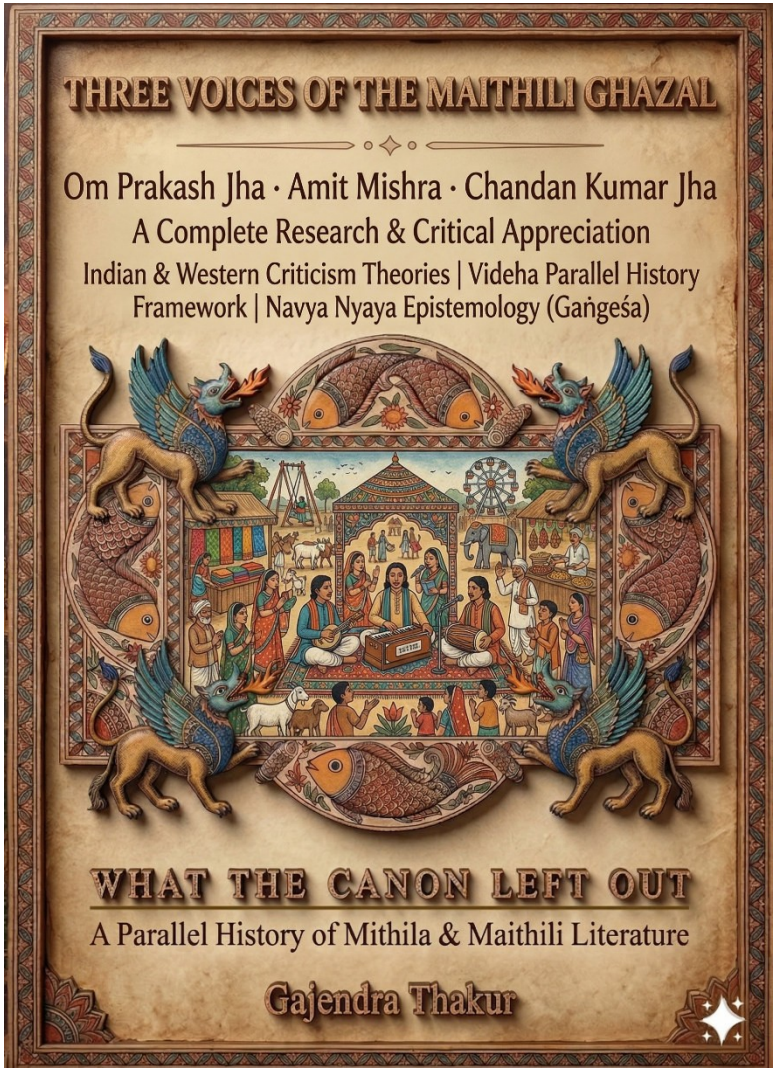
**LESSON 055 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**



# THREE VOICES OF THE MAITHILI GHAZAL

**Om Prakash Jha · Amit Mishra · Chandan Kumar Jha**

*A Complete Research & Critical Appreciation*

Indian & Western Criticism Theories | Videha Parallel History Framework | Navya Nyaya Epistemology (Gaṅgeśa)

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# 1. Introduction: The Anchinhar Akhar Era of Maithili Ghazal

Three slim volumes, published in the same year (2012) by the same press (Shruti Prakashan, New Delhi), priced identically (Rs. 200 each), distributed by the same distributor (Pallavi Distributors, Nirmali, Supaul): Kiyo Bujhi Nai Sakal Hamara by Om Prakash Jha, Nav Anshu by Amit Mishra, and Monak Baat by Chandan Kumar Jha. This simultaneous emergence is not coincidence but consequence — the consequence of a specific moment in Maithili literary history: the consolidation of what Gajendra Thakur has called the 'Anchinhar Yuug' (the 'Anchinhar Akhar Era') of Maithili ghazal writing.

All three poets acknowledge a common genealogy: the Videha eJournal (www.videha.co.in), the Anchinhar Akhar blog (http://anchinharakharkolkata.blogspot.com) run by Sri Ashish Anchinhar, and Gajendra Thakur's foundational Maithili Ghazalshastra (the theoretical manual of Maithili ghazal prosody). All three name the same trio of mentors: Gajendra Thakur (theoretical grounding), Ashish Anchinhar (prosodic training in bahar), and Umesh Mandal (editorial support and encouragement). Om Prakash Jha's preface explicitly names all three: 'These three people are unforgettable for me and will always remain so.'

The three collections — 87 ghazals, 16 rubais, 2 katas in Kiyo Bujhi; 90 ghazals, 6 hazals, 16 rubais in Nav Anshu; 66 ghazals, 2 hazals, 15 baal ghazals, 33 rubais, 1 kata in Monak Baat — constitute a collective literary monument: the first published flowering of the Anchinhar Akhar era of Maithili ghazal writing. Together they contain well over 200 ghazals written by young poets who came to the ghazal form through digital platforms, learned its grammar from an online community, and published simultaneously in print — a publishing model without precedent in Maithili literary history.

This study applies the full range of Indian and Western literary theory — Rasa theory, Dhvani theory, Western lyric theory, intertextuality, postcolonial criticism, New Criticism, reader-response theory — alongside the Videha Parallel History Framework and Navya Nyaya epistemology of Gaṅgeśa to a comprehensive critical appreciation of these three poets and their foundational collections.

## 2. Historical Context: The Maithili Ghazal Tradition

The ghazal entered Maithili literature in the late nineteenth or early twentieth century, with the pioneering efforts of Pandit Jiwan Jha ('Bihari'). Chandan Kumar Jha's preface to Monak Baat provides the most detailed historical account among the three collections, noting that Maithili literary history spans approximately 107 years of ghazal writing. However, this long history was marked by inconsistency and formal ambiguity: much of what was called 'ghazal' in Maithili did not actually follow the strict Arabic-Persian prosodic requirements (the bahar system of quantitative metre), and the kafiya (rhyme)-radif (refrain) system was imperfectly observed.

The critical intervention of the Anchinhar Akhar movement was precisely the insistence on formal rigour: that Maithili ghazal must observe the Arabic-Persian prosodic standards (appropriately adapted to Maithili phonology), that the kafiya must be metrically and phonologically precise, and that the bahar must be consistent throughout a ghazal. Chandan Kumar Jha's preface diagnoses the historical problem: 'Many of the older generation of Maithili ghazalkaras have not yet grasped the Arabic bahar-based prosody and its application in Maithili — which is unfortunate.' The three collections under study represent the Anchinhar era's answer to this historical deficiency.

The Maithili ghazal tradition that the three poets inherit includes: Pandit Jiwan Jha (the founding figure), Gajendra Thakur (the moderniser and theorist), and the generation of writers who emerged through Videha and Anchinhar Akhar — including Shantilakshmi Chaudhary, Mihir Jha, Jagadanand Jha 'Manu', Bibi Jha, Rajiv Ranjan Mishra, Pankaj Chaudhary 'Navali', and others named in Chandan's preface alongside the three poets of this study.

## 3. The Videha-Anchinhar Platform: A Parallel Literary Revolution

The Videha Maithili eJournal (www.videha.co.in, ISSN 2229-547X), edited by Gajendra Thakur since January 2008, and the companion blog 'Anchinhar Akhar' (http://anchinharakharkolkata.blogspot.com) run by Sri Ashish Anchinhar, jointly constituted the platform through which the Anchinhar era of Maithili ghazal emerged. All three poets are explicit about this: Amit Mishra writes: 'In January 2012 I found a guru in Sri Ashish Anchinhar Ji, and

simultaneously found a platform like Videha — I regard this day as my new awakening (nav jagaran).' Chandan Kumar Jha writes: 'The Videha family and Anchinhar Akhar family taught me the meaning of ghazal and inspired me to write ghazal.'

The significance of this platform cannot be overstated for understanding these three collections. All three poets began writing ghazals and sharing them digitally on Facebook groups (the 'Videha' group) and the Anchinhar Akhar blog before they published in print. The immediate feedback loop — writing a ghazal, posting it online, receiving responses from other poets and readers, revising based on technical criticism — constituted the laboratory of formal training that made the print collections possible. This is a model of literary production without precedent in Maithili literary history: the digital-first, community-trained, simultaneously-published emergence of a new generation.

Gajendra Thakur's Videha Parallel History framework is relevant here in its insistence that literary history must reckon with the full ecology of literary production — not only the canonical published works evaluated by institutional critics, but the platforms, communities, and processes through which writers are formed and works circulate. The simultaneous publication of three ghazal collections by three poets from the same online community, by the same publisher, in the same year, is a moment in Maithili literary history that institutional criticism — focused on individual 'major' figures — would likely miss or undervalue. The Parallel History framework makes it visible and significant.

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## 4. The Ghazal as Literary Form: Technical Framework

### 4.1 Arabic-Persian Prosody and Maithili Adaptation

The ghazal is a lyric poem form originating in Arabic and Persian literature (the Arabic tradition traceable to the 7th century CE; the Persian classical ghazal reaching its heights with Hafiz, Rumi, and Sa'di in the 13th-15th centuries; the Urdu ghazal tradition from Mir Taqi Mir and Mirza Ghalib to the 20th century). Its defining formal features are: the matla (opening sher/couplet, where both lines share the same kafiya-radif pattern), the maqta (closing sher, where the poet's takhallus/pen-name appears), the radif (refrain — identical words repeated at the end of each sher's second line and both lines of the matla), the

kafiya (rhyme scheme, preceding the radif), and the bahar (metre — the quantitative prosodic scheme that regulates the length and pattern of syllables).

Maithili adaptation of the ghazal faced the challenge of applying a quantitative prosodic system (the Arabic-Persian bahar, based on the distinction between long and short syllables) to a language (Maithili) with a different phonological structure. Gajendra Thakur's theoretical contribution — the Sarala Varnik Bahar — was to develop a simpler quantitative system based on syllable count (Varnik = syllable count) that allowed new Maithili ghazal writers to observe formal constraints without mastering the full complexity of Arabic prosody. More advanced poets, like those influenced by Ashish Anchinhar's training, attempted the full Arabic bahar system.

## 4.2 Gajendra Thakur's Sarala Varnik Bahar System

The Sarala Varnik Bahar (Simple Syllabic Metre), as described and applied by Gajendra Thakur, requires that every line (pankti) in a ghazal has the same number of syllables (varna). This is explicitly notated by all three poets at the end of each ghazal: 'Varna-13', 'Varna-16', 'Varna-20', etc. Om Prakash's preface explains: 'I believe one should write the Arabic bahar's name or, if in Sarala Varnik Bahar, the syllable count below every ghazal. Therefore I have noted the bahar name or syllable count below all ghazals.' This notational practice — transparent about formal choices — is itself a mark of the Anchinhar era's formalist commitment.

The Arabic bahrs employed by the three poets include: Bahre-Hazaj, Bahre-Ramal, Bahre-Kamil, Bahre-Mutaqarib, Bahre-Mutadarik, Bahre-Basit, Bahre-Muktajib, Bahre-Salim, Bahre-Sagir, Bahre-Kabir. Chandan's preface provides the most comprehensive theoretical account of the bahar system, categorising them into Saman Bahar (uniform metre), Adhasaman Bahar (semi-uniform metre), and Asaman Bahar (non-uniform metre), with examples drawn from Ashish Anchinhar's theoretical framework.

## 4.3 The Makta, Matla, Radif, Kafiya: Technical Vocabulary

The technical vocabulary that all three poets deploy in their prefaces demonstrates their shared theoretical formation. The matla (first sher where both lines share kafiya-radif) is the formal announcement of the ghazal's prosodic contract. The maqta (last sher containing the takhallus — pen name) is the formal signature of the ghazal. Om Prakash uses 'Om' as takhallus; Amit Mishra uses 'Amit'; Chandan Kumar Jha uses 'Chandan'. The radif (identical-word refrain) and kafiya (rhyme) together constitute the sonic architecture of

the ghazal — the web of sound that holds its independently-meaningful shers together.

The sher (couplet) is the fundamental unit of the ghazal: each sher should be semantically complete and independent — able to stand alone as a self-contained poetic statement — while also participating in the larger ghazal through the radif-kafiya system. This structural paradox — the sher's independence within the ghazal's sonic unity — is one of the ghazal form's most distinctive and theoretically interesting features, with important implications for Navya Nyaya analysis of poetic meaning.

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# 5. Om Prakash Jha: Kiyo Bujhi Nai Sakal Hamara

## 5.1 Biographical Context

Om Prakash Jha's collection Kiyo Bujhi Nai Sakal Hamara (Who Could Not Understand Me — Maithili Ghazal, Rubai and Kata; Shruti Prakashan, Delhi, 2012; ISBN 978-93-80538-87-7; Price Rs. 200) is his first published literary work and specifically his first published Maithili ghazal collection. His preface reveals that he considers himself primarily a ghazalkar, though he writes in other genres as well. His pen-name/takhallus is 'Om', which he uses consistently as his maqta signature.

He was born and raised in a family with a literary-intellectual tradition: his father, Sri Pitambar Jha, was always writing, collecting Maithili newspapers and journals, and held socialist political views; his mother, Shrimati Ramkumari Jha, had liberal views that also deeply influenced him. He credits his socialist-humanitarian worldview to both parents. He is married to Shrimati Rekha Jha, who is always his first listener (his 'pehla shrota') — he reads every ghazal to her first, takes her suggestions, and credits her patience and love as the source and inspiration of his ghazal writing.

He describes his emergence as a ghazalkar as the product of Videha's platform and Ashish Anchinhar's influence: 'My emergence as a ghazalkar is purely the result of Anchinhar Akhar and Videha's effort and collaboration.' He learned the formal grammar of ghazal through Gajendra Thakur's Maithili Ghazalshastra, trained in kafiya-radif correction under Ashish Anchinhar's mentorship, and received sustained encouragement from Umesh Mandal. The collection

contains 87 ghazals (plus rubais and katas), covering themes of love, social critique, politics, humour, and spirituality.

## 5.2 Thematic Analysis

Thematically, Om Prakash's ghazals range across four major domains. The romantic/shringara domain is the numerically largest: the separated lover's longing, the beloved's cruelty and indifference ('Nainaki chhuri na chalabuyai sajniya' — 'Do not wield the knife of your eyes, O beloved'), the impossibility of forgetting, and the joy and pain of memory. These are in the classical viraha-shringara register of Maithili lyric poetry, adapting the ancient tradition of the separated lover to the ghazal form.

The social-political domain is where Om Prakash is most distinctive. Several ghazals address inequality, the corruption of democracy, the plight of the poor, and the gap between constitutional promise and social reality: 'Bhikh nai hamara apan adhikar chahi / Hamar karmasank je banai uphaar chahi' (Ghazal 1: 'Not alms do I want, my rights I need / Let my own labour build my reward'). 'Jan-ganak sevak bhela deshak bhaar chai / Jantaak mari taka banal budhiyaar chai' (Ghazal 22: 'The people's servant has become the country's burden / Beating the public, [he] became clever on public money'). These politically engaged ghazals deploy the ghazal's traditional vehicle of love-complaint to carry social-democratic critique — a characteristic move of the best Urdu and Hindi ghazal tradition.

The domain of philosophical reflection includes ghazals on the nature of life, the paradox of existence, and the human condition. Ghazal 9 ('Dharak kaat rahito piyas rahi gel jinngi hamar / Monak baat monahi rahal dukha sahi gel jinngi hamar' — 'Living on the river's bank, thirsty remained my life / The heart's talk stayed in the heart, sorrow endured my life') is a meditation on the irreducibility of existential longing — the paradox that one can have everything (the river, the bank) yet remain thirsty. This is the classical Islamic-Sufi resonance of the ghazal form: the beloved is simultaneously human and divine, and the lover's thirst is simultaneously romantic and spiritual.

The humorous domain is represented by the Murchha Diwas (April Fool's Day) ghazal (No. 85), a comic self-deprecating piece written in the takhallus 'Om': 'Murkha Diwas par pata chala ham sabhsank badaka murkha thikhai' ('On Fool's Day it was learned that I am the biggest fool of all'). This deployment of the ghazal's formal conventions for comic self-deprecation — a tradition with deep roots in the Urdu hazal (comic ghazal) — demonstrates Om Prakash's formal range.

## 5.3 Technical Achievement

Om Prakash employs the largest range of Arabic bahrs among the three poets: Bahre-Ramal, Bahre-Mutaqarib, Bahre-Sagir, Bahre-Salim, Bahre-Basit, Bahre-Hazaj, Bahre-Kabir, Bahre-Muktajib, Bahre-Kamil, and Sarala Varnik Bahar at various syllable counts (Varna 16, 17, 18, 20, 22, 24). This technical range demonstrates serious prosodic study and the ambition to master multiple formal registers. His stronger ghazals are among the most technically accomplished in the Anchinhar era corpus.

## 5.4 Close Reading of Selected Ghazals

Ghazal 4 — whose radif is the collection's title — is Om Prakash at his most characteristic. Its matla: 'Kahu ki kiyo buji nai sakal hamara / Hansi sabhak lagal bahut tharal hamara' ('Say why no one could understand me / Everyone's laughter fell upon me, burning me'). The takhallus sher: 'Rahal Om sidikhna sinehak pujari / I duniya ta kafir muda kahal hamara' ('Om remained always love's devotee / This world called me kafir'). The use of 'kafir' (infidel) — a loaded word from the Arabic-Islamic tradition — to describe the lover/poet's status in the world's eyes is a classic ghazal gesture: the lover who is faithful to love above all social conventions is branded an infidel by the conventional world. This is simultaneously a love poem, a social critique, and a claim on the Sufi-devotional tradition.

Ghazal 10 on the relation between grief, music, and poetic creation: 'Karej ghansais saajaak raag nikhrai chai / Bina dhunne turak nai taag nikhrai chai' ('By scraping the heart, the instrument's melody is refined / Without grinding, the thread does not emerge from the cocoon'). This metaphysical conceit — the paradox that suffering (scraping/grinding) is the condition of beauty (melody/thread) — is achieved within a tightly observed Bahre-Hazaj, demonstrating the Anchinhar era's aspiration to combine emotional depth with formal mastery.

## 5.5 The Rubai and Kata Forms

Om Prakash's rubais (16 in the collection) are in the Persian/Arabic rubai tradition — four-line stanzas with the rhyme scheme AABA. His katas (2 in the collection) are a related form: short poems that do not technically conform to ghazal structure but share its emotional register. These demonstrate his command of forms beyond the ghazal proper, establishing the collection as a multi-form lyric anthology rather than a single-genre collection.

# 6. Amit Mishra: Nav Anshu

## 6.1 Biographical Context

Amit Mishra's Nav Anshu (New Dew Drop — Maithili Ghazal, Hazal & Rubai; Shruti Prakashan, Delhi, 2012; ISBN 978-93-80538-82-2; Price Rs. 200; © Amit Mishra) is his first published collection. His takhallus is 'Amit'. His preface is particularly informative about both his poetic formation and the technical framework of the ghazal. He writes that he began writing in 2008, but regards January 2012 — when he found a mentor in Ashish Anchinhar and a platform in Videha — as his 'new awakening' (nav jagaran). He credits his high school friend Sri Om Prakash Jha (co-author of this triptych) with first giving him the 'courage to write', and Ashish Anchinhar with providing ghazal knowledge. He also credits Gajendra Thakur (for Videha) and Om Prakash Jha (for repeated support along his ghazal journey). Umesh Mandal is credited as typesetter.

Amit Mishra's preface provides the most technically detailed and educationally oriented introduction of the three, containing a full tutorial on ghazal grammar: definitions of sher, ghazal, radif, kafiya, matla, maqta (with examples), and the bahar system. This pedagogical dimension — the preface as a primer on ghazal form for Maithili readers — reflects the Anchinhar era's commitment to democratising technical knowledge. His takhallus ('Amit') and the use of the initial letter 'E' for short (hrasva) syllables and 'I' for long (dirgha) syllables in his metre analysis (mentioned in his preface) shows systematic technical awareness.

## 6.2 Thematic Analysis

Nav Anshu's 90 ghazals cover a thematic range that is primarily oriented toward the romantic (shringara) tradition but with distinctive inflections of contemporary realism and social observation. The opening ghazal — 'Chaan dekhlo ta sitara ki dekhab / Anhaarak rup dobara ki dekhab' (If you've seen the moon, why look for stars / Having seen the form of darkness again, why look?) — establishes the collection's characteristic mode: philosophical observations delivered in romantic garb.

The romantic ghazals are rich in the iconography of the Maithili village landscape: the moon, stars, darkness, monsoon rains, the koyal's call, the

village courtyard, the bride's ornaments (payel/anklet, kangana/bangle, nathiya/nose-ring). Ghazal 3: 'Konak chamkal rup sab / Bujhaho chahai chai / Ang-ang me hamar ghazal rahe chahai chai' ('How every part gleamed / Wants to be understood / My ghazal wants to live in every limb'). This self-referential meta-ghazal — the poem as a physical presence desiring habitation in the beloved's body — is a sophisticated formal gesture: the ghazal about the ghazal, the poem as beloved.

The social-critical dimension in Nav Anshu is less prominent than in Om Prakash's collection but present in significant ghazals. Ghazal 7 addresses dishonesty and social karma with philosophical firmness: 'Karo kato jhut ki kheti beimani / Dakati / Bhagavan ghar me ta hisab phriehbe karai chai' ('However much you cultivate lies and dishonesty / Robbery — God at home will settle accounts'). This combines the moral-didactic tradition of the Maithili folk proverb with the ghazal form's capacity for compressed philosophical statement.

The most distinctively contemporary dimension of Nav Anshu is the cluster of ghazals addressing urban-rural migration and its emotional consequences. Ghazal 8: 'Kona-kona kohbar se Kolkata elai / Rukabo nai karai film jeka bhagaie besi' ('Somehow from the kohbar (wedding chamber) came to Kolkata / Without stopping, runs like a film'). The contrast between the kohbar (the most intimate Mithila domestic space — the wedding chamber decorated with Mithila paintings) and Kolkata (the migrant city) is compressed into a single devastating sher. This is the emotional reality of the Bihari-Maithili diaspora experience: the loss of the kohbar's intimacy in the relentless movement of urban life.

## 6.3 Technical Achievement

Amit Mishra's ghazals are primarily in the Sarala Varnik Bahar (with syllable counts ranging from 11 to 20), reflecting his more careful, graduated approach to the formal system. He also attempts some Arabic bahrs but with less frequency than Om Prakash. The consistency of syllable counting throughout his ghazals demonstrates systematic prosodic discipline. His stronger ghazals achieve a balance between emotional directness and formal control.

## 6.4 Close Reading of Selected Ghazals

Ghazal 6 — 'Aab ta raat bitaeb bhela kathin / Varsha me vastra sukhaeb bhela kathin' ('Now the night has become difficult to pass / In the rains, drying clothes has become difficult') — is simultaneously a realistic depiction of the monsoon-

season domestic difficulty of drying clothes and a metaphorical statement about the difficulties of navigating life's emotional storms. The poem works through what Anandavardhana calls Vastu-Dhvani: the suggested meaning (life's emotional difficulties, the viraha of the separated lover) is resonated through the literal situation (wet clothes, persistent rain). The closing sher: 'Dhadhaik rahal pani me dhadhara dekhu / Amit aagi bujhaeb bhela kathin' ('See the fire burning in water / Amit: extinguishing this fire has become difficult') — the paradox of fire in water — is the ghazal's formal-philosophical climax, achieving through the oxymoron a precise statement of the viraha condition: burning with desire, surrounded by rain, unable to extinguish either.

Ghazal 2, with its radif 'hansi ke kahu' ('say it laughing'), is a master of the ghazal's characteristic mode of wisdom delivered with a smile: 'Je kichu kahab hansi ka kahu / Premak jalme phansi ka kahu' ('Whatever you say, say it laughing / In love's net caught, say it laughing'). Each sher adds a new dimension: 'Bhijao sinehak barsha me / Dilak jhilme dhansi ka kahu' ('Soaked in the rain of love / Sunk in the heart's lake, say it laughing'). The radif 'hansi ka kahu' is not merely a formal requirement but a philosophical position: the wisdom that all life's difficulties must ultimately be expressed with laughter, not bitterness.

## 7. Chandan Kumar Jha: Monak Baat

### 7.1 Biographical Context

Chandan Kumar Jha's Monak Baat (The Heart's Talk — Maithili Ghazal, Hazal, Baal Ghazal, Rubai & Kata; Shruti Prakashan, Delhi, 2012; ISBN 978-93-80538-81-5; Price Rs. 200; © Chandan Kumar Jha) is his first published collection. His takhallus is 'Chandan' (sandalwood — a classical Sanskrit-Maithili symbol of fragrance, coolness, and devotion). His self-description in the preface is notably modest and reflexively self-aware: 'I was not a student of literature (sahitya ka vidyarthi nai chhalai). Therefore many things of literature, its grammar, are unfamiliar to me. Yet I always had attachment to literature... Like any ordinary person, many feelings about my surrounding society, environment, etc. constantly arise in my mind. Many feelings vanish with passing time. Then some of these descend in the form of letters on paper, sometimes as poetry, sometimes as story, sometimes as ghazal, sometimes as rubai and other forms of literature.'

His acknowledgment section is particularly revealing: he names first a teacher ('Jinkara anukampasak kahibyo rinnanh heab — acharya; kanhai' — 'From whose grace I will never be free — teacher; Kanhai') to whose memory he is indebted; then the Videha family and Anchinhar Akhar family. He acknowledges Ashish Anchinhar and Gajendra Thakur by name. He also makes a significant intervention in his preface: a full theoretical essay on Maithili ghazal history and prosody, the most substantial theoretical statement of the three collections — making Monak Baat not only a poetry collection but a critical-historical document.

## 7.2 Thematic Analysis

Chandan Kumar Jha's thematic range is notably the broadest of the three poets. The romantic ghazals are distinctive for their precision of imagery and emotional intelligence. Ghazal 11: 'Ghosh hunkar utar gelai / Jot sagaro pasar gelai' ('Their veil fell / Light spread everywhere'). The falling of the veil (ghosh — the traditional covering a woman draws over her face) is rendered as a cosmic event: when the beloved's veil falls, light spreads everywhere. This is simultaneously a domestic scene (the parda tradition) and a philosophical metaphor (the lifting of Maya/illusion).

The social ghazals are Om Prakash's equal in political directness. Ghazal 12: 'Jinngi ker batpara kantsa garhla chai / Nayat ker tat bedha sagaro daphanal chai / Moy-baap bhai-bandhu chai jhuth hai sambandha sab / Moh-jal ojharaya jinngi gatana chai' ('Life's path has thorns planted everywhere / The reed-fence of the new has been buried all around / Mother-father, brothers — all relationships are false / Life is tangled in illusion's net'). This ghazal — one of the darkest in the three collections — refuses all consolation and names the social and familial structures of Mithila life with unflinching critical distance.

Ghazal 13 is a comic-satirical masterpiece on the theme of the vain and arrogant fool: 'Murkha bada mahan o je apnakai kabila bujai chai / Apan mathak tetarh thakke kakarahu nai sujhai chai' ('The fool is great who considers himself capable / Whose own head's obstacle blocks everyone else's view'). This Hazalesque social satire (in a serious ghazal form) is characteristic of Chandan's capacity to hold comic and serious simultaneously — a skill that finds its fullest expression in his hazal and baal ghazal sections.

The nari-centric ghazals (Ghazal 17: 'Punmaak raatik chaan sana chamkait chai ahaan / Angnaak tulsi chaura sana gamkait chai ahaan' — 'You glow like the full moon's night / You are fragrant like the tulsi tree of the courtyard') render women's experience with sensitivity and precision. The tulsi tree (sacred basil,

always in the centre of the traditional Mithila courtyard, tended by women) as a metaphor for the beloved is both intimate and culturally specific: it locates the love poem within the material ecology of Mithila domestic space.

## 7.3 Technical Achievement: Baal Ghazal and Generic Innovation

The most formally innovative dimension of Monak Baat is the inclusion of 15 Baal Ghazals (children's ghazals) — a genre that Chandan Kumar Jha is among the first in the Anchinhar era to write systematically. The baal ghazal adapts the ghazal's formal structure (matla, radif, kafiya, maqta, bahar) to content appropriate for children: nature imagery, play, learning, seasons, and gentle social values. This generic innovation demonstrates the democratic and pedagogical ambitions of the Anchinhar era: if the ghazal's formal discipline is valuable, it should be accessible to children as well as adults; if Maithili literature needs to develop, it needs forms that can reach the youngest readers.

Sample Baal Ghazal: 'Saone ayal sakala tara / Jhilmil jhilmil karai tara / Kaalo raatike tara chai / Man mein chamkait tara' ('In the evening all the stars come / The stars shimmer, shimmer / Even in the dark night stars / Stars glimmer in the heart'). The formal requirements (syllable count consistency, rhyme scheme) are fully observed, demonstrating that the baal ghazal is not a relaxation of form but its adaptation.

## 7.4 Close Reading of Selected Ghazals

Ghazal 14 — 'Sabad sanga khelaeb hamara nik lagait chai / Sabad hi ojharaeb hamara nik lagait chai' ('Playing with words appeals to me / Even tangling in words appeals to me') — is a meta-poem about the nature of poetic composition, simultaneously a statement of craft and a demonstration of it. The paradox of the second line ('even tangling/getting confused in words appeals to me') acknowledges the difficulty and frustration of writing as part of its pleasure — a sophisticated Romantic-era observation that finds precise expression in the ghazal form's compressed couplet structure.

Ghazal 15 is among the most musically accomplished in all three collections: 'Kauwa kuchaural bhore angana sancha parait authi sajan / Chham-chham-chham-chham payala bajai khanak uthal kangana' ('The crow called early in the courtyard — at dusk the beloved will come / The anklet rang chham-chham, the bangle jingled'). The onomatopoeia ('chham-chham-chham-chham') for the anklet's sound is a technical tour de force within the Sarala Varnik Bahar's syllable-count constraint, and the crowded domestic imagery (the crow, the

courtyard, the anklet, the bangle, the sandalwood-fragrant courtyard) evokes the richness of Mithila's sensory domestic world with extraordinary economy.

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# 8. Indian Literary Theory Applied to the Ghazal

## 8.1 Rasa Theory (Bharata Muni's Natyashastra)

Bharata Muni's Rasa theory (Natyashastra, c. 200 BCE–200 CE) identifies eight primary aesthetic emotions: Shringara (love), Hasya (humour), Karuna (pathos), Raudra (fury), Vira (heroism), Bhayanaka (terror), Bibhatsa (disgust), Adbhuta (wonder), with Shanta (peace) as a ninth later addition. The ghazal form, by its very nature and historical tradition, privileges Shringara Rasa (love) as its primary mode — the very word 'ghazal' in Arabic denotes 'to speak of love' or 'love talk with women.'

In all three collections, Shringara Rasa dominates — specifically Vipralambha Shringara (love in separation), which is the most emotionally intense and formally productive mode. The archetypal ghazal situation is the separated lover addressing an absent or indifferent beloved: this situation generates the full range of viraha (separation) emotions — longing, grief, memory, reproach, self-pity, philosophical resignation. The radif (refrain) structure formally embodies this repetitive emotional state: the same words return at the end of each sher, as the lover returns to the same obsession.

Hasya Rasa appears in the hazal (comic ghazal) sections of all three collections, and in Om Prakash's April Fool ghazal. Karuna Rasa predominates in the social-critique ghazals (the poor man's plight, the political manipulation of the poor). Vira Rasa appears in Om Prakash's ghazal on rights and resistance ('Bhikh nai hamara apan adhikar chahi'). Adbhuta appears in the metaphysical conceits: fire burning in water (Amit), the ghazal wanting to live in the beloved's body (Amit), light spreading when the veil falls (Chandan).

## 8.2 Dhvani Theory (Anandavardhana)

Anandavardhana's Dhvanyaloka (9th century CE) — the theory of suggestive resonance (Dhvani) as the soul of poetry — is particularly central to the ghazal form, which is structurally dependent on suggestion, indirection, and layered meaning. The ghazal's characteristic mode is Rasa-Dhvani — the suggestion of

an entire emotional-aesthetic state through minimal verbal means. Each sher is a tiny world of compressed suggestion; the whole ghazal is an architecture of resonances.

The concept of Yamaka (repetition for resonance) is directly relevant to the radif structure: the identical words of the radif, returning in different semantic contexts with each sher, create a Dhvani-like resonance effect. When Om Prakash's radif 'hamara ki' ('to me what') returns in each successive sher with a new context, the cumulative effect is not merely repetition but deepening resonance — each sher adding a new layer to the meaning of the radif phrase.

Anandavardhana's concept of Bhakasakti (expressive power of linguistic units) — the idea that some words carry more concentrated suggestive power than others — helps explain why certain ghazal images (the moon, the moth and flame, the wine and the cup, the wound and the arrow) are so pervasive and productive: they are words of maximum Dhvani-potential in the ghazal tradition, capable of carrying enormous weight of suggestion in minimal space.

## 8.3 Vakrokti (Kuntaka) and the Oblique Voice

Kuntaka's Vakroktijivita (10th century CE) — the theory of 'oblique expression' as the essence of literary language — is directly applicable to the ghazal's constitutive indirection. The ghazal never directly states its emotion; it obliquely approaches through metaphor, paradox, irony, and the play of the kafiya-radif system. When Om Prakash writes 'Chhadhi raho hamara ki / Bada mahal ahan thokait raho hamara ki' ('Leave me alone — what's it to me / You build great mansions — what's it to me'), the speaker's apparent indifference is a Vakrokti — an oblique expression of the lover's wound, which precisely because it cannot be said directly is said through its apparent denial.

The takhallus/maqta (pen-name sher) is itself a structural Vakrokti: the poet speaks of himself in the third person, creating a formal distance between the biographical self and the lyric self. When Om Prakash writes "Om' kahait rahat anhin sojha-sojha gapp' ('Om will keep saying these straight-forward words'), the apparent claim of direct speech is itself oblique — the self-naming as 'Om' distances the speaker from the reader and creates the classic ghazal irony of the poet as both subject and observer of his own emotion.

## 8.4 Reeti Theory and the Register of Ghazal

The Reeti (style) school of Sanskrit poetics (Vamana's Kavyalankarasutravritti, 9th century CE) identified different stylistic registers (Reetis) appropriate to

different literary genres and occasions: Vaidarbhi (soft, Maithili-like), Gaudi (dense, ornate), and Panchali (balanced). The Maithili ghazal in the Anchinhar era is characteristically in a mixed register: the formal requirements of the Arabic bahar impose a certain sonic density (Gaudi) while the Maithili vernacular and the social-realistic themes tend toward the clearer, more direct register. The three poets navigate this tension differently: Chandan tends toward the denser, more imagistic Gaudi register; Amit toward the simpler, more direct Panchali; Om Prakash moves between both depending on the theme.

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# 9. Western Literary Theories

## 9.1 Lyric Theory and the Confessional Mode

The Western tradition of lyric theory — from the Romantic conception of the lyric as 'spontaneous overflow of powerful feelings' (Wordsworth) to the modernist 'objective correlative' (T.S. Eliot) to the confessional mode (Sylvia Plath, Robert Lowell) — provides a comparative framework for understanding the Maithili ghazal's lyric operations. The ghazal's self-naming (takhallus) convention is neither Romantic spontaneity nor modernist impersonality but something distinctive: a structured, formal self-reference that simultaneously constitutes and distances the poetic self.

The confessional mode — poetry as direct personal testimony — partially applies to the Anchinhar era ghazal: all three poets write from evident personal emotional experience, and the immediacy of the prefaces (which describe personal relationships, family dynamics, and professional contexts) blurs the boundary between confessional autobiography and lyric convention. However, the ghazal's formal constraints (bahar, kafiya, radif, takhallus) impose a degree of formalisation that prevents pure confessionalism: the personal emotion must pass through the formal filter of the ghazal's grammar before it can become a poem.

## 9.2 Intertextuality (Kristeva, Bakhtin)

Julia Kristeva's concept of intertextuality — that all texts are tissues of quotation, absorbed and transformed from other texts — is structurally inscribed in the ghazal tradition through the takhallus system, the conventional imagery (moon, wine, moth, flame), and the shared prosodic framework. All

three poets are writing within and against a dense web of intertexts: the Urdu ghazal tradition (Mir, Ghalib, Faiz), the Hindi ghazal (Dushan Dushyant Kumar), and the emerging Maithili ghazal corpus. The radif and kafiya choices, the image selection, and the takhallus signature are all intertextual acts — gestures of participation in and differentiation from the tradition.

Bakhtin's concept of dialogism — the idea that all utterance is inherently responsive to and anticipatory of other utterances — applies to the ghazal's takhallus convention. When Om Prakash writes 'Om kahait rahat' ('Om keeps saying'), he is not merely naming himself but entering into dialogue with every other ghazalkar who has similarly named themselves in their maqta: the takhallus is a dialogic act, positioning the poet within the community of ghazal writers. This is particularly significant in the Anchinhar era, where all three poets belong to the same online community and many of their ghazals were first published and responded to on the same digital platforms.

## 9.3 Postcolonial Theory: Language Politics and Ghazal

The appropriation of the Arabic-Persian ghazal form by Maithili language — a language historically undervalued by both colonial and post-colonial Indian state institutions — is itself a significant postcolonial cultural act. By demonstrating that Maithili can sustain the formal rigour of the Arabic bahar system, the Anchinhar era poets assert Maithili's cultural sophistication against both Hindi (which has absorbed much of the North Indian ghazal tradition) and Urdu (the primary carrier of the classical ghazal tradition in South Asia).

Frantz Fanon's analysis of cultural production in colonised languages — the argument in The Wretched of the Earth that literature in the national language is an act of cultural reclamation — applies to the Anchinhar era Maithili ghazal. Writing technically demanding ghazals in Maithili, at the same level of formal rigour as Urdu or Hindi, is a cultural-political act: it asserts the adequacy of Maithili as a medium for high literary expression. The explicit naming of the bahar, the careful notation of kafiya and radif, the pedagogical prefaces — all these are assertions of Maithili's capacity to sustain the full technical apparatus of the classical ghazal tradition.

## 9.4 New Criticism: Paradox, Tension, and the Sher

New Criticism's identification of paradox, irony, and tension as the marks of literary achievement (Cleanth Brooks, Robert Penn Warren) finds precise application in the ghazal's structural features. The sher's requirement for complete semantic independence within the ghazal's sonic unity creates an

inherent structural tension: each sher is simultaneously autonomous and constrained, free and bound. The best shers in all three collections achieve a paradoxical density — they are both complete statements and suggestions, both literal and figurative, both personal and universal.

Brooks's concept of 'the well-wrought urn' — the poem as a self-contained, internally consistent aesthetic object — maps onto the individual sher's structural independence: each sher is a miniature well-wrought urn. Om Prakash's sher 'Karej ghansais saajaak raag nikhrai chai / Bina dhunne turak nai taag nikhrai chai' is a well-wrought sher: the two lines create a tight analogical structure (grief:music :: grinding:thread) that is internally consistent, paradoxically rich, and complete in itself.

### 9.5 Reader-Response Theory (Iser, Fish)

Wolfgang Iser's reader-response theory — the idea that literary meaning is co-created between text and reader through the process of reading — is particularly relevant to the ghazal's characteristic structural gap: the sher's independence from its neighbors creates what Iser calls 'blanks' (gaps in the text that the reader must fill). The Maithili ghazal reader is invited to make connections between apparently unrelated shers, to find the emotional and thematic thread that runs beneath the formal surface. This active reading process — filling the ghazal's structural gaps — is the reader-response dynamic that makes the form so engaging.

Stanley Fish's concept of 'interpretive communities' — groups of readers who share interpretive conventions — is directly applicable to the Anchinhar era ghazal readership. The Videha online community, the Anchinhar Akhar blog readers, and the Facebook ghazal group participants constitute precisely such an interpretive community: they share the technical vocabulary (bahar, kafiya, radif, takhallus), the emotional conventions (viraha as the primary mode), and the cultural context (Maithili diaspora experience) that give the ghazals their full meaning. For readers outside this community, the ghazals require more explanatory context; for community members, they resonate with immediate recognition.

## 10. The Videha Parallel History Framework

Gajendra Thakur's Videha Parallel History Framework provides the most essential contextual framework for understanding these three collections and

their literary-historical significance. The framework's core claim — that official Maithili literary history has systematically undervalued non-elite, non-institutional, digitally-circulated literary production — is nowhere more directly illustrated than in the case of the Anchinhar era Maithili ghazal.

The three collections were produced by poets who: (a) are not from the traditional literary elite of Darbhanga or Madhubani; (b) received their literary training primarily through digital platforms rather than academic institutions; (c) published their first collections simultaneously at their own or the community's expense; and (d) wrote in a literary form (the ghazal) that has only recently gained acceptance within mainstream Maithili literary culture. Without the Videha Archive, the Anchinhar Akhar blog, and the Videha Facebook community, none of these three poets would have had the platform, the training, or the peer community to develop their craft to publishable level within such a short time.

The Parallel History framework also helps understand the significance of the three collections' simultaneous publication. In conventional literary history, major literary figures emerge serially and individually, with canonical status determined by institutional endorsement (prizes, critical essays, academic study). The Anchinhar era produced a cohort — simultaneously, collectively, democratically. No single figure dominates; the achievement is communal. This collective emergence is precisely what Gajendra Thakur's Parallel History project documents and values: the literary movement, not merely the individual genius.

The Videha Archive's preservation of these three collections ensures that the Anchinhar era ghazal's historical significance is documented and accessible. Without this archival commitment, three slim volumes published by a small Delhi publisher in 2012 would be difficult to locate; with the Videha Archive, they are part of the permanent record of Maithili literary history.

## 11. Navya Nyaya Epistemology Applied to Ghazal

Navya Nyaya — the school of Indian logic and epistemology that arose in Mithila with Gaṅgeśa Upadhyaya's Tattvacintamani (c. 1325 CE) — offers a distinctive framework for analysing the epistemological operations of the ghazal form. The application is not merely metaphorical but culturally

grounded: these ghazals are produced within the Mithila cultural tradition that also produced Gaṅgeśa and the entire Navya Nyaya school.

## 11.1 Pramana in Poetic Cognition

The four Pramanas (sources of valid knowledge) — Pratyaksha (perception), Anumana (inference), Upamana (comparison), Shabda (testimony) — each operate distinctively in the ghazal reading experience. The Pratyaksha of the ghazal is the immediate sensory experience of the sound-pattern: the bahar's rhythmic pulse, the kafiya-radif's sonic architecture, the phonological texture of Maithili words. This is the level at which a ghazal can be heard and experienced even without understanding every word — the music of the form as direct perceptual experience.

Anumana (inference) is activated when the reader infers emotional states and social situations from the ghazal's compressed imagery. When Amit Mishra writes 'Kona-kona kohbar se Kolkata elai' ('Somehow from the wedding chamber came to Kolkata'), the reader infers the full emotional situation (migration, cultural displacement, loss of intimacy) from the single juxtaposition of kohbar and Kolkata. This inferential leap — from two place-names to a life-history — is the Anumana of the ghazal's compressed form.

## 11.2 Vyapti and the Logic of the Sher

Gaṅgeśa's central technical contribution to Navya Nyaya — the precise analysis of Vyapti (invariable concomitance) — is directly applicable to the ghazal's analogical structures. The best shers in all three collections rest on implicit Vyaptis: invariable concomitances between natural phenomena and emotional states that the reader is expected to recognise. Om Prakash's sher on the heart as an instrument — 'By scraping the heart, the instrument's melody is refined' — rests on the Vyapti: where there is creative suffering, there is artistic achievement. This is presented as universal truth (Vyapti), and the reader's recognition of this truth is the aesthetic experience of the sher.

Navya Nyaya's sophisticated analysis of Upadhi (limiting conditions that restrict Vyaptis) is relevant to the social-critical ghazals. The apparent Vyapti 'where there is the poor, there is the politician's promise; where there is the promise, there is betrayal' is presented by Om Prakash as an invariable concomitance of contemporary Indian political life. The Upadhi (limiting condition) would be the exception — the honest politician — which the ghazal conspicuously does not acknowledge, suggesting that the Vyapti holds without exception in the world the poet describes.

## 11.3 Shabda Pramana and the Radif-Kafiya System

In Navya Nyaya, Shabda Pramana (valid verbal testimony) operates through the Tatparya (purport/intended meaning) of an utterance. The ghazal's radif-kafiya system creates a distinctive form of Shabda Pramana: the repeated radif word/phrase, returning in each sher, accumulates Tatparya across the ghazal, building a complex of meanings that cannot be reduced to any single sher. When Chandan Kumar Jha's radif 'hamara nik lagait chai' ('I find pleasing') returns again and again in Ghazal 14, it accumulates a Tatparya of aesthetic pleasure, intellectual delight, and professional identity that only emerges fully in the sum of all shers.

The Apta (reliable witness) concept in Navya Nyaya — the speaker whose Shabda Pramana is valid because they have direct and authoritative knowledge — is relevant to the takhallus convention. The ghazal's maqta self-naming constitutes the poet as Apta: by naming himself, the poet claims the authority of first-person witness to his own emotional experience. Om Prakash's 'Om rahala sidikhna sinehak pujari' ('Om remained always love's devotee') is simultaneously a claim to Apta-hood (I testify from my own experience) and a formal poetic act (the maqta of the ghazal).

## 11.4 Gaṅgeśa's Tatparya and the Ghazal's Multiple Meanings

Gaṅgeśa's concept of Tatparya — the total intended meaning of an utterance, going beyond its literal semantic content — is particularly illuminating for the ghazal's characteristic multi-layeredness. The best ghazal shers carry multiple simultaneous Tatparyas: the literal romantic meaning, the social-political allegorical meaning (in the tradition of the Persian-Sufi ghazal's use of love as code for spiritual or political longing), and the self-reflexive meta-poetic meaning. Om Prakash's 'I duniya ta kafir muda kahal hamara' ('This world called me kafir') carries simultaneously: the lover rejected by society, the socialist rejected by the establishment, the poet marginalised by conventional literary culture, and the Sufi devotee branded heretic by the orthodox.

Gaṅgeśa's analysis of Anuvyavasaya (metacognitive awareness of one's own cognitive processes) is applicable to the three poets' extraordinarily reflexive prefaces, in which they think carefully about their own formation, their learning process, their debts and limitations, and the epistemological conditions of their poetic authority. This metacognitive transparency is itself a Navya Nyaya-like quality: the rigorousness and self-awareness of the reasoner applied to the domain of poetic creation.

## 12. Comparative Analysis of the Three Poets

Comparing Om Prakash Jha, Amit Mishra, and Chandan Kumar Jha across thematic, technical, and temperamental dimensions reveals three distinct poetic personalities within a shared formal and communal context.

Thematically: Om Prakash is the most politically engaged and socially critical, the most philosophically ambitious, and the most tonally varied (ranging from intense romantic lyric to comic self-deprecation to democratic rage). Amit Mishra is the most consistently romantic in register, with the sharpest eye for the migrant's emotional landscape (the kohbar-Kolkata juxtaposition is his most distinctive image). Chandan Kumar Jha is the most formally ambitious (baal ghazal, hazal, the fullest theoretical preface), the most metatextually self-aware, and the most cinematically specific in imagery (the courtyard crow, the anklet's chham-chham, the tulsi tree).

Technically: Om Prakash attempts the widest range of Arabic bahrs and achieves the greatest technical variety. Chandan demonstrates the most systematic formal range (through the baal ghazal innovation). Amit is the most consistent in syllable discipline within the Sarala Varnik framework. All three show the influence of their shared formation — none of the three has yet fully mastered the Arabic bahar system's complex requirements, but all three demonstrate serious and sustained formal engagement.

Temperamentally: Om Prakash is passionate, direct, and politically alive; Amit is tender, meditative, and emotionally nuanced; Chandan is philosophically cool, formally adventurous, and socially incisive. These temperamental differences are visible in the takhallus-sher choices: Om Prakash's maqtas are frequently declamatory or ironic; Amit's are tender or self-deprecating; Chandan's are philosophically precise.

## 13. Thematic Synthesis

### *a. Love as the Ground of All Other Themes*

Across all three collections, love (in all its registers: romantic, familial, devotional, national) is the ground from which all other themes emerge. The social critique is expressed through the vocabulary of love (the beloved's

indifference as the politician's indifference); the philosophical meditation uses love's paradoxes (the thirsty man on the riverbank); the patriotic sentiment is the love of the motherland; the devotional impulse is love of the divine. The ghazal form, with its inherent orientation toward love, shapes this thematic convergence.

### *b. Digital Modernity and Traditional Form*

All three collections emerge from a deeply modern, digital context (Facebook groups, blogs, online journals) yet are written in a classical form (the ghazal's Arabic-Persian prosodic tradition). This juxtaposition — contemporary platform, classical form — is itself a statement about the Maithili literary condition: a language asserting its modernity by demonstrating its command of tradition. The ghazal's formal rigour is not antiquarian nostalgia but a claim on cultural seriousness.

### *c. Community and Individuality*

The three collections are simultaneously deeply individual (each poet's voice is distinct) and communally produced (through shared training, shared platform, shared publisher, shared year). This tension between individual voice and communal formation mirrors the ghazal's own structural tension between the independent sher and the unified ghazal. The community is the larger ghazal; each poet is one of its independent shers.

### *d. The Mithila Diaspora Experience*

Migration from Madhubani/Supaul to Kolkata, Delhi, or other cities; the emotional landscape of the absent beloved (often = the absent homeland); the kohbar left behind for the city's anonymity — these are recurring motifs that give all three collections a distinctively diaspora character. The ghazal form, with its constitutive viraha (separation) structure, is the ideal formal vehicle for the Maithili diaspora's emotional world.

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## 14. Conclusion and Critical Assessment

Om Prakash Jha, Amit Mishra, and Chandan Kumar Jha represent a generational watershed in Maithili literary history: the first published cohort of the Anchinhar Akhar era, the moment when the digital literary community constituted by Videha and Anchinhar Akhar produced its first substantial print

harvest. Their three collections — Kiyo Bujhi Nai Sakal Hamara, Nav Anshu, and Monak Baat — taken together constitute the founding document of this era.

Their collective achievement is both formal and social. Formally, they demonstrate that the Arabic-Persian ghazal's prosodic demands can be observed in Maithili, and that the Maithili ghazal can carry the full emotional, philosophical, and political weight of the form. Socially, their simultaneous emergence from a democratised digital community challenges the institutional literary culture's gatekeeping function: they did not need the approval of Sahitya Akademi or university syllabuses to develop their craft and reach an audience.

The critical appreciation of these three poets requires the full range of theoretical frameworks applied in this study: Indian Rasa and Dhvani theory (to understand the emotional-aesthetic operations of the form), Western lyric and postcolonial theory (to situate the form's cultural-political significance), the Videha Parallel History Framework (to understand the literary-historical significance of the Anchinhar era), and Navya Nyaya epistemology (to analyse the form's distinctive truth-producing operations). No single framework is adequate; the full portrait requires the convergence of all.

In the terms of Navya Nyaya: their ghazals are Aptavakya — the valid testimony of reliable witnesses — to the emotional and social reality of Mithila's diaspora communities in the early twenty-first century. In the terms of Bharata's Natyashastra: they achieve Lokasangraha — the social holding-together through art — by giving their communities' unspoken emotional experiences a formal and shareable shape. In the terms of Vidyapati's own formulation (invoked by the Kamal-Taal preface): their love — for the Maithili language, for the ghazal form, for their communities — 'grows new moment by moment,' tila tila nutana hoe.

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## Online Resources


- Videha Archive: www.videha.co.in/pothi.htm
- Anchinhar Akhar Blog: http://anchinharakharkolkata.blogspot.com
- Videha eJournal archive of ghazals: www.videha.co.in/archive.htm

**LESSON 056 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**

COMPLETE CRITICAL APPRECIATION PRADEEP PUSHPA

Ghazal Poet · Cultural Commentator · Digital Writer

Indian & Western Literary Theory · Videha Parallel History Framework
Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa · Ghazal Poetics · Rasa-Dhvani-Vakrokti]

WHAT THE CANON LEFT OUT

A Parallel History of Mithila & Maithili Literature

Gajendra Thakur

# COMPLETE CRITICAL APPRECIATION

# PRADEEP PUSHPA

*Ghazal Poet · Cultural Commentator · Digital Writer*

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## I. BIOGRAPHICAL PROFILE

### A. Origins and Formation

Pradeep Pushpa (प्रदीप पुष्प) is a Maithili ghazal poet, song-writer, and cultural essayist from Nanour village, Madhubani district, Bihar — the heartland of Mithila's cultural geography. His biographical self-account in 'Apna Kichu Bāt' (अप्पन किछु बात), the author's preface to his ghazal collection Monak Dehairpar (2020), reveals a formation that is characteristic of the Videha Parallel History's democratic literary tradition: literary and musical sensibility nurtured at home, schooling in a semi-rural setting, and discovery of the ghazal form through the internet and the Videha digital community rather than through formal academic training.

Literature and music pervaded his household from childhood. His father (Baba) was his first teacher in both domains. At school, three teachers shaped his literary sensibility: Krishnamohan Jha (Yogibābu, Bhavam), Jayanandan Jha (Hindi teacher), and Basukīnāth Jhā (Nanour). He also acknowledges Prof. Kamar Husain. He began writing songs (gīta) in high school and produced many cassettes in various styles, but found no lasting satisfaction until the ghazal form drew him.

His initial engagement with ghazal was self-taught, through listening to Hindi-Urdu ghazals on Kantipur FM radio during teaching stints in Nanour. Around 2003–2005 he began reading ghazal formally, but remained unaware of its grammar and metre (bahr). In 2008 he first attempted ghazal composition — candidly acknowledging in retrospect that these early attempts were 'not

actually ghazals'. In 2012, when mobile internet became accessible, he encountered ghazal shastrā (grammatical theory) systematically.

The decisive turning point was a visit by Umesh Mandal to his village with an invitation to post on 'Videha ī-caubiṭiyā' (the Videha digital platform). This brought him into contact with the core community of Maithili ghazal writers who had been developing the form under Gajendra Thakur's editorial leadership: Gajendra Thakur himself, Ashish Anchinhar, Amit Mishra, Rajiv Ranjan Mishra, Kundan Karṇa, and Omprakash Jhā. Ashish Anchinhar provided extensive help with bahr and prosodic discipline.

## B. Family and Location

Pradeep Pushpa's wife Nīlū Pushpa (नीलू पुष्प) is described as the first listener of his ghazals — an acknowledgment that locates the creative process within the domestic sphere rather than in the seminar hall or literary club. His student Jaya Śrīti prepared the manuscript. He dates his author's note from Nanour, Madhubani, 5 March 2020 — the place of both his origin and his ongoing practice, signalling that his ghazal career is rooted in the Madhubani landscape rather than in a metropolitan literary establishment.

His takhallus (pen-name used in the maqta verse) is 'Pushp' (पुष्प) — the Maithili/Sanskrit word for flower. This takhallus, already present in his surname, is lightly worn: it appears in several maqta verses (Ghazal 6: 'Pushpa golak bānhame gherā rahal chī'; Ghazal 10: 'Jā rahal Pushpa sāṛā sapanā lene rinavāsa ker'; Ghazal 11: 'Pushpakeṃ nai fikara ā ne māna mītā') with a characteristic self-referential irony.

## C. Videha Archive Presence

Pradeep Pushpa's presence in the Videha digital archive spans multiple Sadeha collected editions:

Videha Sadeha 14 (Prelim_14): One ghazal, page 720.

Videha Sadeha 16 (Prelim_16): Shers, rubaī, ghazals, 'Ghazal ka Ghazal', 'Tūṃ', 'Kaṭhaputerīkeṃ Nāca', 'Yai Ahāṃ', gīta — pages 524–535.

Videha Sadeha 20 (Prelim_20): Essay 'Sinehiyā: Jagā ka Ṭīsa Hṛdayame Keheana Kaṭhora Bhelaum' (pages 16–19); Valentine Special Ghazals and Kichu Ghazal (pages 842–846).

Videha Sadeha 22 (Prelim_22): 'Kichu Ghazal' — pages 674–729 (55 pages — his most substantial Videha appearance).

Videha Sadeha 23 (Prelim_23): Kichu rubaī, kichu ghazal — pages 1196–1200.

Videha Sadeha 24 (Prelim_24): Critical essay 'Gītakāra Rāmlocana Ṭhākura' (pages 133–136).

Videha Sadeha 25 (Prelim_25): Critical essay 'Gītaka Apratima Śilpakāra: Ravīndra Nātha Ṭhākura' (pages 364–367); 2 rubaī and 2 ghazals (pages 382–384).

Videha Sadeha 36 (Prelim_36): Gajendra Thakur's review of Pushpa's ghazal collection Monak Dehairpar listed in contents.

## II. WORKS: ANNOTATED CATALOGUE

### A. Ghazal Collection

मोनक देहिरपर (Monak Dehairpar — On the Enchanting Threshold)

Pallavi Parkashan, Nirmali/Berma, District Supaul, Bihar. First published 2020. ISBN 978-93-88811-52-1. Price ₹200. 103 pages. Typeset by Manav Arts, Nirmali. Copyright: Pradeep Pushpa.

This is Pradeep Pushpa's first and as yet sole published book — a collection of Maithili ghazals prefaced by Ashish Anchinhar ('Ghazal Pushpa') and the author's own note. The book contains at least 19 numbered ghazals covering the full range of the Videha Maithili ghazal tradition: social protest, political satire, migration and urban alienation, love and betrayal, cultural erosion, village life, and the poet's own artistic self-questioning.

The title Monak Dehairpar (मोनक देहिरपर) deserves analysis. Dehira (देहिर/देहरी) is the Maithili/Bhojpuri word for the threshold, the doorstep — the liminal space between inside and outside, between the domestic and the public, between arrival and departure. Mona(k) (मोनक) derives from mona — the heart/mind/soul. 'On the enchanting threshold' or 'On the threshold of the heart' — the title thus evokes the ghazal's essential quality of liminality: the ghazal always stands at a threshold, between presence and absence, between love fulfilled and love denied, between the private world of feeling and the public world of social critique.

### B. Videha Contributions: Prose and Critical Essays

'Sinehiyā: Jagā ka Ṭīsa Hṛdayame Keheana Kaṭhora Bhelaum' (सिनेहिया: जगा क' टीस हृदयमे केहेन कठोर भेलौं) — Videha Sadeha 20, pages 16–19. An essay on the theme of sinehiyā (beloved/dear one) as a literary and emotional concept. The title, 'Having awakened the sting in the heart, how hard you have become', is a ghazal-like utterance in itself — it compresses the entire Maithili ghazal's dominant emotional register into a single vocative phrase.

'Gītakāra Rāmlocana Ṭhākura' (गीतकार रामलोचन ठाकुर) — Videha Sadeha 24, pages 133–136. A critical appreciation of the Maithili song-composer and writer Ramlochan Thakur, demonstrating Pushpa's engagement with the Videha Parallel History's project of documenting the democratic Maithili literary tradition. That Pushpa writes on a gīta-composer (rather than a ghazal-poet) reflects his own formation: he came to ghazal through gīta, and maintains connections to the song tradition.

'Gītaka Apratima Śilpakāra: Ravīndra Nātha Ṭhākura' (गीतक अप्रतिम शिल्पकार: रवीन्द्र नाथ ठाकुर) — Videha Sadeha 25, pages 364–367. A critical essay on Ravindra Nath Thakur as an 'incomparable craftsman of song', situating the Maithili song tradition within a broader aesthetic framework.

### C. Rubaīyāt

Pradeep Pushpa has published rubaīyāt (the Persian/Urdu quatrain form) in Videha Sadeha 23 and 25, demonstrating engagement with the full range of the ghazal's related Persian-origin forms as developed in the Maithili Videha tradition. The rubaī (رباعی) — a four-line poem with AABA or AAAA rhyme scheme — is structurally distinct from the ghazal but shares its prosodic framework (bahr) and its takhallus convention.

## III. FORMAL ANALYSIS: GHAZAL CRAFT IN MONAK DEHAIRPAR

### A. The Maithili Ghazal: Brief Genealogy

Ashish Anchinhar's preface to Monak Dehairpar provides a succinct genealogy of the formal Maithili ghazal tradition as understood within the Videha

community. He traces the bahr — specifically the metre 2122+2122+2122+212 (the ḥazaj-based metre dominant in Hindi-Urdu progressive ghazal from Nirālā through Dushyant Kumar) — from its earliest Maithili practitioners to Pushpa's generation. The preface cites Nirālā, Dushyant Kumar, Adām Gondavī, and Hasrat Mohānī as the formative influences, demonstrating that the Videha Maithili ghazal is conscious heir to both the formal Urdu-Persian ghazal tradition and the Hindi 'new ghazal' (nayī ghazal) of the post-Independence period.

Within Videha, the Maithili ghazal was developed by Gajendra Thakur (who pioneered its revival from around 1905 onwards in the Videha framework), and then by Ashish Anchinhar whose 'revival' of the form in the digital era established its contemporary standards. Pradeep Pushpa is explicitly situated by Anchinhar as a member of this second generation of Videha ghazal writers.

## B. Bahr (Prosodic Analysis)

Each ghazal in Monak Dehairpar carries a bracketed bahr notation — a feature characteristic of the Videha Maithili ghazal tradition under Gajendra Thakur's editorial practice, which treats metrical transparency as a pedagogical obligation to the reader. The notations use a numerical system (2=dīrgha/long syllable, 1=laghu/short) derived from the classical Maithili prosodic tradition adapted for the Arabic-Persian bahr system.

Ghazal 1 (2222221222): Mixed bahr with internal variation — the 'error' in the third sher (noted by the author as intentional concession) demonstrates honest prosodic self-assessment.

Ghazal 2 (2222222222): Pure 2222222222 per line — likely ḥazaj musaddas with long form; 6 shers with uniform radif 'delauṃ'.

Ghazal 3 (2122 2112 2211 22): Mixed vārṇik-based bahr; 3rd and 4th shers take the first line's ending as long.

Ghazal 4 (222212212222): Variant of ramal bahr; Delhi migration as central motif.

Ghazal 5 (212 12 22): Simple vārṇik bahr — one of the 'simple metre' ghazals Anchinhar identifies as pedagogically oriented.

Ghazal 6 (2122 2122 2122): Standard ḥazaj musaddas — the classic Dushyant-Adām metre; 5 shers including maqta with takhallus 'Pushpa'.

Ghazal 7 (2222222): Short bahr — Dushyant-style two-line shers with political bite.

Ghazal 8 (2222222222): Long 10-syllable per hemistich; political-social protest.

Ghazal 9 (2222222222222): 13-syllable bahr; cultural erosion theme.

Ghazal 10 (22222222222222): 14-syllable longest bahr; 5 shers, maqta with 'Pushpa'.

Ghazal 11 (2122 1222 2122): Mixed bahr; 5 shers, maqta with 'Pushpa'.

### C. The Radif and Rhyme System

The radif (refrain) in each ghazal is the most expressive formal choice. Pushpa's radifs reveal his thematic preoccupations: 'lebai hama' (I will do/take) — assertion/action; 'gelauṃ hama' (I went/have become) — journey/transformation; 'rahal jīnagī' (life remains) — endurance; 'rahal chī' (is/am/are) — state of being; 'bala loka' (that/such people) — social critique; 'karatai' (they do/will do) — observation of social behaviour; 'kon gāma chai' (what village is this?) — alienation; 'ker' (of/for) — genitive relation; 'mītā' (O friend!) — intimate address.

The most complex radif is 'ī kon gāma chai' (Ghazal 9) — 'what village is this?' — a six-word radif that enacts the ghazal's central question in its very structure. Each sher poses a feature of the alienated village (no turmeric-market smells, no Sohara or Lagani songs, only DJ noise; old parents abandoned; dog lounging on a sofa) before the refrain delivers its rhetorical question of belonging and estrangement.

## IV. THEMATIC ANALYSIS: THE GHAZAL UNIVERSE

### A. Social Protest and Political Satire

Pradeep Pushpa's ghazals operate in the tradition of the Hindi progressive nayī ghazal — the tradition of Dushyant Kumar's 'Ho gaī hai pīr parvat-sī pighalanī cāhie' and Adām Gondavī's 'Bhūkha ke aha sāsa ko śe Rosukhan taka le calo'. His Ghazal 7, whose maqla (opening sher) 'Gamakait ghāma bala loka / Camakait cāma bala loka' (Those who sweat in the sun; those whose skin shines) and second sher 'Bhāṣaṇa āmo par dai chai / Thurīṃ latāma balā loka' (Those who give speeches over our mangoes; those who trample the treetops) — cited specifically by Anchinhar in his preface as exemplary — belongs

squarely in this tradition. The sardonic contrast between the rhetoric of political speech and the reality of agricultural exploitation is a direct descendant of Dushyant Kumar's ironic juxtapositions.

Ghazal 1 is perhaps the most sustained political poem: its five shers address dowry violence (a daughter's wedding expenses paid by selling the field; petrol drums brought to the courtyard when a girl is burned), hypocrisy (washing others' dirty linen while hiding one's own scandal), administration (the government kept in one's pocket as a toy), and communal politics in the third sher — all compressed into the tight two-line structure with uniform radif 'lebai hama'.

Ghazal 8 is a masterpiece of political layering: the first sher shows a farmer selling his field to fund a daughter's wedding; the second shows a politician who drinks at night and runs anti-addiction campaigns in the morning; the third shows flood victims whose land is destroyed by the embankment; the fourth shows the petty humiliation of those who speak without a patron; the fifth addresses a hungry ruler who divides the nation along religious lines; and the final maqla sher shows the world dancing to the pārthaka (partisan) victory cry — a devastating six-sher indictment of the political economy of rural Bihar.

## B. Migration, Urban Alienation and the Delhi Experience

Ghazal 4's radif 'gelauṃ hama' (I have gone/become) structures a meditation on the poet's arrival in Delhi: 'Nai keoa mīta nai prema churache ṭākā / Kī bheṭala āba Dillī ṭhaharī gelauṃ hama' — 'No friend, no touch of love costs a paisa; what did I find? I arrived in Delhi and got stuck.' The sher captures the migrant's disillusionment with the city: the promised richness of human connection reduced to monetary transaction.

The village-Delhi axis is a recurring structural motif. Ghazal 7's final sher — 'Karatai uddhāra Mithilāka / Dillī asāma bala loka' (Those from Delhi and Assam who say they will uplift Mithila) — is a biting observation on the political class that claims to serve Mithila from metropolitan distances while the actual Madhubani-Supaul rural population sustains their claims.

Ghazal 9's entire dramatic structure — 'ī kon gāma chai?' (What village is this?) — is a meditation on the village that has become unrecognisable: the Sohara and Lagani folk songs replaced by DJ noise; the smell of turmeric and curd-rice replaced by Chinese food stalls; old parents abandoned; the courtyard populated by a dog on a sofa. The village has become a simulation of itself, hollowed out by modernity.

## C. Love, Betrayal and the Ghazal's Classical Register

Ghazal 2 explores betrayal and the resolution to self-assertion: 'Phaera Ṭhamakala tohara dalāna laṣaga je / Chātī pāthara kaṣa Ḍega sasāri delaum' (Again I stumbled at your courtyard's threshold; crushing the stone on my chest, I will move on). The threshold (dalān) of the beloved's house is the poem's central image — directly echoing the collection's title Monak Dehairpar. The last sher delivers the characteristic ghazal resolution: 'Cāna dhiri pāhuṃcaba nai likhala chala hamrā / Monakeṃ hama Sīṛhīsāṃ utāri delaum' (That we would reach the moon was never written in our fate; I will dismount the heart from its ladder).

Ghazal 6 uses the imagery of spiritual dissolution: 'Bītalāhā bāṭame herā rahal chī' (Lost on a pathless road is this life) with the maqta 'Mana bhelalai bhoja kiratauṃ gāma bharika / Pushpa golaka bānhame gherā rahal chī' (The mind longed to wander village to village; Pushpa is caught in the encirclement of his ball-and-chain). The 'golak bānh' (encirclement of a sphere/prison) is a vivid image of the poet's entrapment — whether in social obligation, urban life, or artistic limitation.

## D. Cultural Erosion and the Village

Ghazal 9's radif 'ī kon gāma chai?' operates as a cultural diagnostic. The sher 'Nai soharā nai laganī ā chai nai nacārīka dhuna / Sagaro māṭra Ḍīje bajaia chai ī kon gāma chai' (There is no Sohara, no Lagani, no Nācārī tune; only DJ music plays everywhere — what village is this?) is one of the collection's most resonant cultural observations. The Sohara (birth song), Laganī (wedding processional), and Nācārī (a form of Maithili devotional song) represent the entire life-cycle song tradition of Mithila — exactly the tradition that Hriday Narayan Jha documented as endangered in the Videha Sadeha 1 essay. Pushpa's ghazal connects to that documentation tradition: the poet's complaint is the cultural critic's lament in compressed form.

## E. The Poet's Self-Reflection: Art and Commitment

Ghazal 3 is among the collection's most programmatic statements: 'Hama likhait chī loka lae, vidvāna lae naya / Hama gabai chī gāma lae, jajamāna lae naya' (I write for the people, not for the scholar; I sing for the village, not for the patron). This sher articulates the Videha Parallel History Framework's central democratic commitment with rare directness. The contrast loka/vidvān

(people/scholar) and gāma/jajamāna (village/patron) is the definitional antithesis of the parallel literary tradition.

Ghazal 11 continues this self-reflective strand: 'Dosarakar gīta ugabai achi cāna mītā / Hamara ghazalo gabai bhūkhaka gāna mītā' (Others' songs are celebrated, O friend; our ghazal too sings the song of hunger, O friend). The poet accepts his marginal position without self-pity, asserting the dignity of the committed art even when it lacks the institutional recognition given to 'celebrated' songs.

## V. THEORETICAL FRAMEWORKS

### A. Rasa-Dhvani Analysis

Bharatamuni's theory of rasa and Ānandavardhana's dhvani provide the primary Indian critical framework for Pushpa's ghazals. The dominant rasas across the collection are Karuṇa (pathos — the sustained emotional register of loss, migration, and cultural erosion), Vīra (heroic resolve — the determination to write 'for the people', to persist against betrayal), and Hāsya/Raudra in combination in the satirical political ghazals (Ghazals 1, 7, 8). The interplay of Karuṇa and Vīra — suffering acknowledged but not surrendered to — is the characteristic rasa-configuration of the Videha Maithili ghazal tradition.

Dhvani operates most powerfully in the radif choices. The radif 'ī kon gāma chai?' (What village is this?) does not merely ask a question; it dhvanis the entire experience of estrangement, of watching one's native place become unrecognisable, of the grief that accompanies cultural transformation. The question is not answered — it cannot be — and the unanswered refrain is itself the most resonant dhvani in the collection.

### B. Vakrokti and Auchitya

Kuntaka's vakrokti (oblique expression) is consistently present in Pushpa's political shers. The apparently straightforward observation 'Bhāṣaṇa āmo par dai chai / Thurīṃ latāma balā loka' (Those who give speeches over our mangoes; those who trample the treetops) operates vakrokti at several levels simultaneously: the literal image (a political speech delivered in a mango orchard, trampling the branches), the metaphorical (the politician using the people's resources as the stage for self-promotion), and the satirical (the sheer incongruity of political rhetoric and the physical reality of the orchard).

Kshemendra's auchitya (contextual propriety) is tested by the collection's range of registers — from the intimate love-ghazal (Ghazal 2, 6) to the didactic political sher (Ghazal 1, 8) to the elegiac cultural lament (Ghazal 9). Each register requires its own auchitya, and Pushpa's skill lies in calibrating tone appropriately: the satirical political shers are terse and direct; the love-ghazals are more imagistic and allusive; the cultural lament ghazals build their argument cumulatively through the sher sequence.

## C. Navya-Nyāya and Śabda-Pramāṇa

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's epistemological framework of śabda-pramāṇa (verbal testimony as valid knowledge) is relevant to the ghazal's claim to be a form of knowledge. The ghazal sher, in the Urdu-Persian tradition, is considered a self-sufficient unit of valid utterance — its two lines constitute a complete perceptual-inferential-linguistic act. In the Navya-Nyāya terms that Gaṅgeśa develops in the Tattvacintāmaṇi's Śabda-khaṇḍa, a linguistic utterance is valid (pramā) when it accurately represents reality, when the speaker has the relevant knowledge, and when the communication is undistorted. Pushpa's political shers satisfy all three conditions for śabda-pramāṇa: they represent observed social reality (the farmer selling land for dowry, the politician drinking at night, the DJ replacing Sohara), they come from a positioned knower with direct access to this reality (a Madhubani rural writer), and they communicate without distortion — the sher's compression is not obscurity but precision.

The anumāna structure of Pushpa's satirical ghazals is particularly Navya-Nyāya in character. In Ghazal 8, the hetu (logical reason) of each sher is a specific observed social fact, the vyāpti (universal concomitance) is the connection between that fact and the systemic hypocrisy/injustice it reveals, and the sādhya (proposition to be established) is the critique of the political-social order. The ghazal's sher-sequence thus enacts a series of inferential moves, each building the overall anumāna towards the maqla's devastating conclusion.

## D. Videha Parallel History Framework

Pradeep Pushpa is a paradigmatic figure for the Videha Parallel History Framework. His literary formation was entirely digital and community-based: he did not encounter Maithili ghazal in a university or through a print publication, but through the Videha ī-caubiṭiyā platform and through direct mentorship from Ashish Anchinhar and the example of Gajendra Thakur. His book is published by Pallavi Parkashan — a small regional publisher in

Nirmali, Supaul, not a Delhi or Patna mainstream press. His themes — migration, village erosion, political hypocrisy, cultural loss — are precisely the themes that the Videha Parallel History privileges as the living concerns of the democratic Maithili community.

Ghazal 3's programmatic statement ('I write for the people, not for the scholar; I sing for the village, not for the patron') is a precise articulation of the Parallel History's alternative aesthetic: it explicitly rejects both the academic establishment (vidvān) and the patronage system (jajamān) in favour of a democratic, community-rooted practice. This is not merely a rhetorical position but a biographical fact: Pushpa teaches at a school in Nanour, Madhubani, and writes ghazals for a community that includes farmers, teachers, and rural professionals.

## E. Western Critical Frameworks

Antonio Gramsci's concept of the 'organic intellectual' (Prison Notebooks) precisely describes Pushpa's position. Unlike the traditional intellectual (the pandit, the academic critic) who is detached from the producing class, the organic intellectual emerges from within it and articulates its experiences and aspirations. Pushpa's Ghazal 3 — 'I write for the people, not for the scholar' — is a Gramscian manifesto of organic intellectual identity. His ghazals on farmer distress (Ghazal 8), migration (Ghazal 4), and cultural erosion (Ghazal 9) are the organic intellectual's articulation of the rural Maithili community's lived experience.

Mikhail Bakhtin's theory of heteroglossia (The Dialogic Imagination, 1981) is relevant to Pushpa's ghazals' multi-register quality. Each ghazal contains within itself multiple social voices: the voice of the political satirist, the voice of the migrant worker, the voice of the cultural mourner, and the voice of the committed artist. The radif, repeated across all shers, provides the unifying thread that holds these voices in dialogic tension rather than resolving them into a single monological stance.

Frantz Fanon's analysis of the national intellectual's passage from assimilation through cultural rediscovery to committed creative production (The Wretched of the Earth, 1961) maps onto Pushpa's poetic biography: from the initial assimilation of the dominant (Hindi-Urdu ghazal) form, through the discovery of its Maithili possibilities within the Videha community, to a committed production that deploys the form in service of the Maithili democratic community's self-expression.

## VI. CRITICAL SYNTHESIS

Pradeep Pushpa's Monak Dehairpar occupies a specific and significant position in the Videha Maithili ghazal tradition. As a first collection, it shows the characteristic strengths of the form's second generation within Videha: technical competence developed through digital mentorship, strong thematic focus on the social-political realities of rural Bihar, and an honest self-awareness about the limitations and aspirations of the ghazal project. The self-annotating bahr notation in each ghazal is itself a remarkable feature — it turns the collection into a semi-pedagogical document, demonstrating the poet's commitment to metrical transparency and his awareness of his own occasional prosodic licence.

The collection's greatest achievements are the political-satirical ghazals (1, 3, 7, 8) where Pushpa's directness and specificity of observation — dowry violence, flood damage, DJ culture replacing Sohara — give the ghazal form a grounded social reality that is harder to achieve in the more abstracted love-registers. Ghazal 9 ('ī kon gāma chai?') is the collection's most successful single poem, achieving in its sustained radif-driven structure the kind of cumulative emotional and intellectual impact that the best ghazals generate.

Areas for further development include the love-ghazals, where the imagery — threshold, moon, ladder — sometimes tends toward the conventional, and the maqta verses, where the takhallus 'Pushpa' is not always deployed with the full self-critical irony that the best Urdu-Persian and Hindi ghazal traditions bring to the poet's self-naming. But these are the natural growing edges of a first collection, and the Videha community's collective mentorship — Anchinhar's bahr guidance, Thakur's editorial framework, the example of the broader ghazal tradition — gives Pushpa a productive environment for continued development.

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**A PARALLEL HISTORY OF MAITHILI LITERATURE**

GHAZAL ANALYSIS

**PRADEEP PUSHPA**

प्रदीप पुष्प

*Monak Dehairpar — Close Reading of Selected Ghazals*

*Indian & Western Literary Theory · Videha Parallel History Framework*

*Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa · Ghazal Poetics · Rasa-Dhvani-Vakrokti*

# I. CLOSE READING: TEN GHAZALS

This volume presents close readings of ten ghazals from Pradeep Pushpa's Monak Dehairpar (Pallavi Parkashan, 2020), with metrical analysis, rasa-dhvani-vakrokti annotations, Navya-Nyāya epistemological analysis, English translations, and contextualisation within the Videha Parallel History Framework. The ghazals are presented in order as they appear in the collection.

**GHAZAL 1 — Bahr: 2222221222 | Radif: 'lebai hama'**

Theme: Dowry violence, political hypocrisy, social protest | Shers: 5 | Maqla with refrain

लगलेमे हीया हारि लेबै हम
छातीमे मुक्का मारि लेबै हम

हमरा नै मिललै चान गगनक तेँ
करबै की डिबिये बारि लेबै हम

खगता किनको नै दऽर दियादक आब
आँगनमे अमती गाड़ि लेबै हम

कलपै बाजै बेटी तिलक कारण
डिब्बा पेट्रोलक ढारि लेबै हम

जेबीमे रखने छी प्रशासन हम
क्यो एगो लेतै चारि लेबै हम □

(2222221222 सभ पाँतिमे। तेसर शेरक अन्तिम लघु छूट तौर पर लेल गेल अछि)

*Translation: 'We will beat ourselves in the heart if we lose courage. / We have not found the moon from the sky, so what to do? We will light our own lamp. // No one fears the kinsfolk now; we will plant the bitter neem in our own courtyard. // The daughter cries for dowry; we will pour the petrol drum. // We have kept the administration in our pocket; whoever takes one, we will make four.'*

Rasa: The dominant rasa oscillates sharply between Raudra (fury — the petrol drum verse; the political corruption verse) and Karuṇa (pathos — the daughter crying for dowry). This oscillation is the ghazal's emotional logic: the same social system that produces the daughter's dowry-grief produces the political corruption. The two rasas are not in conflict but in causation.

Dhvani: The maqla's 'legaleme hīyā hāri lebai hama' (we will beat ourselves in the heart if we lose courage) is a complex self-address that dhvanis both individual resolve and collective resilience. The first-person plural 'hama' (we) is not confessional but communal: this is the ghazal of a community speaking to itself.

Vakrokti: Sher 4 ('kalpai bājai beṭī tilaka kāraṇa / ḍibbā peṭrolaka ḍhāri lebai hama') is the collection's most vivid vakrokti: the juxtaposition of the daughter weeping and the petrol drum creates a violent, oblique image of dowry murder — the sher does not name the crime directly but places its instruments in devastating adjacency.

Navya-Nyāya: Each sher is a micro-anumāna. In sher 2: hetu = moon not found; vyāpti = when what we seek is unavailable from outside, we make our own; sādhya = we will light our own lamp. In sher 4: hetu = daughter weeps for dowry; vyāpti = the persistence of dowry demands leads to violence; sādhya (unstated but implied by 'ḍibbā peṭrolaka ḍhāri') = the violence of dowry murder. The unsaid sādhya is the dhvani.

**GHAZAL 3 — Bahr: 2122 2112 2211 22 | Radif: 'lae naya'**

Theme: Democratic artistic commitment | Shers: 5 | Central programmatic statement of the collection

हम लिखैत छी लोक लए विद्वान लए नय
हम गबैत छी गाम लए जजमान लए नय

पेटमे कूदत मूस तहन पागे करतय की
हम खेतै छी भूख लए सम्मान लए नय

हम जनैत छी देव हमर जेबीक लचार

हम पुजैत छी भक्ति लए वरदान लए नय

छैक हमरो लोभ अपन बिन जाइ अहाँक
हम तकैत छी नेह लए पकवान लए नय

भूमिका छैत छोट मुदा नमहर सपना छैत
हम कनैत छी टोल लए खनदान लए नय □

*Translation: 'I write for the people, not for the scholar. / I sing for the village, not for the patron. // When mice jump in the belly, what use is rage? / I eat for hunger, not for honour. // I know our god is as poor as our pocket; / I worship for devotion, not for boons. // I too have desire; I cannot live without you; / I seek love, not delicacies. // The role is small but the dream is large; / I cry for the neighbourhood, not for the dynasty.'*

Rasa: This ghazal sustains Vīra-rasa (heroic resolve) throughout its five shers, modulated by the Karuṇa of the second sher (hunger) and the Śṛṅgāra of the fourth (love). The overall emotional register is one of principled commitment — the vīra is not military but moral.

Videha Parallel History: The maqla — 'I write for the people, not for the scholar; I sing for the village, not for the patron' — is the most direct articulation of the Videha Parallel History's democratic literary programme in Pushpa's collection. The contrast loka/vidvān directly maps onto the Parallel History's opposition between the democratic tradition and the canonical establishment; the contrast gāma/jajamān maps onto its opposition between community-rootedness and patronage-dependence.

Navya-Nyāya: The anaphoric 'hama X lae, Y lae naya' structure (I do X for [reason A], not for [reason B]) is an epistemological clarity-formula — it distinguishes the speaker's actual motivation (pramā) from false attributions. This is a form of niyāmakadharmī-pratyakṣa (determining-property perception): the speaker's direct perception of his own motivations, distinguished from social misrepresentation.

**GHAZAL 7 — Bahr: 2222222 | Radif: 'bala loka'**

Theme: Political satire (Dushyant tradition) | Shers: 5 | Short bahr, dense imagery

गमकैत घाम बला लोक
चमकैत चाम बला लोक

भाषण आमो पर दै छै
थुरीं लताम बला लोक

बाँटै दरद सगरो खूब
ई झंडु बाम बला लोक

मौंसो केर हाट लगबै
गाँधीक गाम बला लोक

करतै उद्धार मिथिलाक
दिल्ली असाम बला लोक □

*Translation: 'Those who sweat and toil in the sun; those whose skin shines. // Those who give speeches over our mangoes; those who trample the treetops. // Those who distribute pain everywhere generously; those with their Jhandū Bām [pain relief balm, a well-known brand]. // Those who will set up a market even for the monsoon-season; those from the village of Gandhi. // Those who will uplift Mithila; those from Delhi and Assam.'*

Rasa: Hāsya (satirical comedy) dominates — the 'Jhandū Bām wala loka' (those with the Jhandū Bām) sher is genuinely funny in its juxtaposition of distributing pain and offering a topical analgesic. But Raudra (controlled fury) underlies the

last three shers. The combination is characteristic of the Dushyant-school political ghazal.

Vakrokti: The entire ghazal operates through nominal characterisation — each sher describes a type ('those who...') rather than making an explicit statement. This indirect characterisation is a sustained vakrokti: the criticism is enacted in the description rather than stated in the judgement. The reader fills in the unstated sādhya.

Dhvani: The final sher's dhvani is the most resonant: 'those from Delhi and Assam who will uplift Mithila' — the dhvani is the impossibility of distant metropolitan politicians claiming to serve a region they have abandoned or never inhabited. The distance (Delhi/Assam vs Mithila) is the unstated critique.

**GHAZAL 9 — Bahr: 2222222222222 | Radif: 'ī kon gāma chai'**

Theme: Cultural erosion and village alienation | Shers: 5 | The collection's masterpiece

भाषा भिन्ने भिन्न बजैत छैत ई कोन गाम छैत
केओ केकरो नै चिन्हैत छैत ई कोन गाम छैत

नै तरुआ तिलकोर नै दही चूड़ा गमिक रहल
गन्ध चाउमिनकेर अबैत छैत ई कोन गाम छैत

नै सोहर नै लगनी आ छैत नै नचारीक धुन
सगरो मात्र डीजे बजैत छैत ई कोन गाम छैत

बूढ़ माए बापकेँ कोन बेटा रखतै संगे
धुर! सभ सबहक मुँह तकैत छैत ई कोन गाम छैत

सून छैत दलान आ भकोभम्म भेल आँगन घर

चिढ़ कऽ सोफा कुकुर हँसैत छैत ई कोन गाम छैत □

*Translation: 'Everyone speaks a different language; no one recognises anyone — what village is this? // No fried taros, no tilkor greens, no smell of curd-rice remaining; only the smell of Chinese noodles drifting — what village is this? // No Sohara, no Lagani, not a tune of Nācārī; only DJ music playing everywhere — what village is this? // What son will keep old parents by their side? Everyone just watches everyone else's face — what village is this? // The courtyard is empty, the outer room desolate; a dog perches on the sofa, laughing in contempt — what village is this?'*

Rasa: Pure Karuṇa-rasa (pathos), developed cumulatively through five shers of increasing specificity. The final image — the dog laughing on the sofa as the courtyard lies empty — achieves the rasa's peak through a reversal: the animal occupies the domestic space abandoned by humans, an image simultaneously absurd (hāsya) and heartbreaking (karuṇa).

Dhvani: The repeated radif 'ī kon gāma chai?' is the single most powerful dhvani in the collection. Its literal meaning (what village is this?) dhvanis: What has become of my village? Is this still my village? Does this place any longer deserve to be called a village? The question is structurally unanswerable — and the unanswered question is the poem's emotional core.

Cultural Connection: The Sohara and Laganī mentioned in Sher 3 connect directly to Hriday Narayan Jha's essay 'Luptraprāya Maithilī Lokagīta' (Videha Sadeha 1), which identifies these very genres as endangered. Pushpa's ghazal is the creative counterpart to Jha's documentary essay: where Jha catalogues and mourns the loss of folk song genres, Pushpa embeds their disappearance in a ghazal sher that gives it emotional immediacy.

Navya-Nyāya: The anumāna of this ghazal is cumulative. Each sher provides a separate hetu (specific sign of cultural dissolution); the vyāpti is the general principle that when the specific markers of a community's life (food, song, human care, domestic space) disappear, the community itself is dissolving; the sādhya is the unstated conclusion — that this village has ceased to be a village in any meaningful cultural sense.

**GHAZAL 11 — Bahr: 2122 1222 2122 | Radif: 'mītā'**

Theme: Artistic solidarity and self-commitment | Shers: 5 | Intimate register

दोसरक गीत उगबैत अछि चान मीता
हमर गजलो गबैत भूखक गान मीता

आब रुदल बऽनब ने हम गऽछब किहयो
जरल पेटसँ उठैत ने सुर तान मीता

भेल बटुआसँ तगमाकेँ नीक दोस्ती
बिन टका छी सभा मध्ये आन मीता

जैह देबै अहाँ हम रखबैत हुलिसकेँ
गाय बूढ़ो खपैत विप्र- दान मीता

पाँतमे हम अछोपक छी भोज खाइत
'पुष्प'केँ नइ फिकर आ ने मान मीता □

*Translation: 'Others' songs rise like the moon, O friend; / Our ghazal too sings the song of hunger, O friend. // Now I will not cry or weep; / No tune rises from a burning belly, O friend. // My wallet has made good friends with my pocket-lining; / Without money I am a stranger in the assembly, O friend. // Whatever you give, I will hug with joy; / Even old cows are used, O friend, for Brahmin donations. // I sit at the end of the feast row, untouchable; / Pushpa has neither worry nor honour, O friend.'*

Rasa: Śānta-rasa (tranquillity arrived at through acceptance) prevails, undergirded by Karuṇa (pathos of poverty, marginalisation). The maqta's takhallus verse — 'Pushpa has neither worry nor honour' — achieves a Śānta-

rasa resolution: the complete acceptance of the poet's marginal position, without bitterness, is a form of liberation.

Videha Parallel History: The maqla — 'Others' songs rise like the moon; our ghazal too sings the song of hunger' — positions the Videha ghazal tradition in explicit contrast to commercially successful or institutionally celebrated songs. The ghazal 'of hunger' is not a complaint but a badge of honour — the work that addresses the community's actual experience rather than its aspirational fantasies.

The maqta's 'pāṃtame hama achopaka chī bhoja khāita / Pushpakeṃ nai phikara ā ne māna mītā' (I sit at the end of the feast row, among the untouchables; Pushpa has neither worry nor honour) introduces a striking social image: the 'pāṃta' (feast row) in Mithila's traditional Brahmin feasts has a strict hierarchical seating order, with 'achopa' (untouchable/low-caste) diners at the far end. Pushpa places himself — the Madhubani school-teacher and ghazal-poet — among the marginalized at the feast, asserting both his social solidarity and his artistic independence from the prestige economy.

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ANNOTATED GHAZAL ANTHOLOGY

**PRADEEP PUSHPA**

प्रदीप पुष्प

*मोनक देहिरपर — Annotated Bilingual Anthology*

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*Indian & Western Literary Theory · Videha Parallel History Framework*

*Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa · Ghazal Poetics · Rasa-Dhvani-Vakrokti*

# EDITORIAL INTRODUCTION

This volume presents ten ghazals from Pradeep Pushpa's Monak Dehairpar (Pallavi Parkashan, Nirmali-Berma, Supaul, Bihar, 2020; ISBN 978-93-88811-52-1) in bilingual annotated form: original Maithili text, literary English translation, and critical annotations covering prosodic form, rasa, dhvani, social context, and connections to the Videha Parallel History Framework. The ghazals are presented in the sequence they appear in the collection.

Editorial note on metre: Each ghazal carries Pushpa's own bahr notation (in brackets at the foot of each poem) using the numerical system standardised in the Videha Maithili ghazal tradition: 2=dīrgha (long/heavy syllable), 1=laghu (short/light syllable). This notation is reproduced as printed. The takhallus 'Pushpa' (पुष्प) appears in the maqta (final sher) of several ghazals.

## GHAZAL 1

Bahr: 2222221222 (all lines) — third sher: short ending taken as licensed variation. | Radif: 'lebai hama' (I will take/do) | Shers: 5

**MAITHILI TEXT:**

लगलेमे हीया हारि लेबै हम
छातीमे मुक्का मारि लेबै हम

हमरा नै मिललै चान गगनक तेँ
करबै की डिबिये बारि लेबै हम

खगता किनको नै दऽर दियादक आब
आँगनमे अमती गाड़ि लेबै हम

कलपै बाजै बेटी तिलक कारण
डिब्बा पेट्रोलक ढारि लेबै हम

जेबीमे रखने छी प्रशासन हम
क्यो एगो लेतै चारि लेबै हम □

**ENGLISH TRANSLATION:**

*If our courage fails at the start, we will beat ourselves in the chest. / Since we couldn't find the moon from the sky, what is there to do? — we will light our own lamp. // No one fears kinsmen anymore; we will plant the bitter neem tree in our own courtyard. // The daughter weeps for the groom's dowry demands; we will pour the petrol drum. // We keep the administration in our pocket; whoever takes one, we will make four.*

**ANNOTATIONS:**

*Social context: This ghazal is the collection's most concentrated political protest poem. Sher 1 opens with an internal resolve ('we will not lose courage'). Shers 2–4 depict specific rural Bihar realities: abandonment by kin, the dowry violence epidemic (sher 4's petrol drum — the instrument of bride burning — placed in devastating adjacency to the weeping daughter), and political corruption (sher 5's 'administration in our pocket').*

*Radif significance: 'Lebai hama' (I will take/do) is an active, volitional radif — each sher ends with the first-person assertion of action. Even in the face of systemic violence, the speaker's agency is asserted. This transforms the social protest poem from a lament into a defiance.*

*Sher 4 is the collection's most striking vakrokti (oblique expression). The daughter's weeping and the petrol drum are placed in adjacent lines without any explicit causal connection — the reader completes the horrifying logic. This is the ghazal form's compression at its most powerful.*

## GHAZAL 2

Bahr: 2222222222 (all lines; two hemistich-final shorts taken as licensed variations) | Radif: 'delaum' (I did/gave up) | Shers: 6

**MAITHILI TEXT:**

फ्रेम टांगल छैत चित्र उखाड़ि देलौं
कानि भरि मोन तोरा बिसारि देलौं

पएर ठमकल तोहर दलान लऽसग जे
छाती पाथर कऽ डेग ससारि देलौं

आस छल जिनगी रचबैत गजल जेना
बहर कठिन छैत हम हिया हारि देलौं

देखल नै गेल पराजय तोहर तेँ
हम अपने अपनाकेँ बजारि देलौं

तूँ पीठेमे चकू भोकबेँ कते
तोरा लेल छाती उघारि देलौं

चान धरि पहुँचब नै लिखल छल हमरा
मोनकेँ हम सीढ़ीसँ उतारि देलौं □

**ENGLISH TRANSLATION:**

*I took down the framed picture and tore it up; crying my fill, I forgot you. // My feet stumbled again at your courtyard's threshold; making my chest into stone, I moved on. // My hope was to compose a ghazal like life itself; but the bahr is hard, and I gave up hope. // Unable to watch your defeat, I sold myself in the marketplace. // How many times will you stab me in the back? — I bared my chest for you. // It was never written that I would reach the moon; I dismounted my heart from the ladder.*

**ANNOTATIONS:**

*This is the collection's most sustained love-ghazal. The threshold imagery — 'tuhara dalāna laṣaga' (your courtyard's threshold) — echoes the collection's title Monak Dehairpar (On the enchanting threshold). The beloved's threshold is the liminal space of the ghazal itself: the threshold between arrival and departure, between hope and resignation.*

*Sher 3 is the collection's most self-referential verse: 'My hope was to compose a ghazal like life; but the bahr is hard and I lost heart.' The ghazal's formal difficulty (bahr) mirrors the difficulty of life itself — a meta-poetic statement embedded in the love register.*

*The final maqla sher — 'It was never written that I would reach the moon; I dismounted my heart from the ladder' — achieves Śānta-rasa through acceptance. The ladder of aspiration (sīṛhī) is an image of the ghazal's own*

*formal structure: the ascending steps of the sher-sequence, each one a step toward the unattainable. Dismounting is not defeat but wisdom.*

## GHAZAL 3

Bahr: 2122 2112 2211 22 (mixed; 3rd and 4th shers: first-line ending taken as long) | Radif: 'lae naya' (not for) | Shers: 5

**MAITHILI TEXT:**

हम लिखैत छी लोक लए विद्वान लए नय
हम गबैत छी गाम लए जजमान लए नय

पेटमे कूदत मूस तहन पागे करतय की
हम खेतैत छी भूख लए सम्मान लए नय

हम जनैत छी देव हमर जेबीक लचार
हम पुजैत छी भक्ति लए वरदान लए नय

छैक हमरो लोभ अपन बिन जाइ अहाँक
हम तकैत छी नेह लए पकवान लए नय

भूमिका छैत छोट मुदा नमहर सपना छैत
हम कनैत छी टोल लए खनदान लए नय □

**ENGLISH TRANSLATION:**

*I write for the people, not for the scholar. / I sing for the village, not for the patron. // When mice jump in the stomach with hunger, what use is rage? / I eat for hunger, not for honour. // I know my god is as poor as my pocket; / I worship for devotion, not for boons. // I have desire too; I cannot be without you; / I seek*

*love, not delicacies. // My role is small but my dream is large; / I cry for the neighbourhood, not for the dynasty.*

**ANNOTATIONS:**

*The Videha Parallel History's most direct articulation in Pushpa's collection. The loka/vidvān (people/scholar) and gāma/jajamāna (village/patron) contrasts encapsulate the democratic vs canonical literary opposition that defines the Parallel History Framework.*

*The anaphoric structure — 'hama X lae, Y lae naya' — repeated five times, creates a cumulative manifesto effect. Each sher adds a new dimension: artistic commitment (sher 1), material reality (sher 2), spiritual honesty (sher 3), personal desire (sher 4), communal solidarity (sher 5).*

*Sher 5's maqla — 'My role is small but my dream is large; I cry for the neighbourhood, not for the dynasty' — closes the manifesto with a precise calibration of humility and ambition: the poet acknowledges his small social position (chhota bhūmikā) while refusing to limit his commitment to the 'dynasty' (khanadāna — the established literary lineage/institution).*

## GHAZAL 6

Bahr: 2122 2122 2122 (all lines; maqta: first-line final short taken as long) | Radif: 'rahal chī' (is remaining / I am) | Shers: 5 + maqta with takhallus 'Pushpa'

**MAITHILI TEXT:**

बीतलाहा बाटमे हेरा रहल छी

ऍँठ छी हम चाह तेँ सेरा रहल छी

पेरलक दैबा भऽ तेना ने कसैया

मेहमे बऽरदे जकाँ पेरा रहल छी

देह भेलैत आब अनमन टाँट सनठी

आगि लागल ऊक सन फेरा रहल छी

मीत मुसकी बीच कननी हैत अलगे
नोर सुख दुखकेर हम बेरा रहल छी

मन भेलैत भोज किरतौं गाम भरिक
'पुष्प' गोलक बान्हमे घेरा रहल छी □

**ENGLISH TRANSLATION:**

*I am lost on a pathless road; / I am hungry with longing, so I am withering away. // Fate has pressed me like the village oil-presser; / I am being pressed like a bullock in the grinding pit. // The body has become dry and brittle like a bamboo stake; / A fire is lit, like a torch I am revolving. // In a friend's smile there is hidden weeping; / I am a blend of tears of joy and sorrow. // The mind wanted to feast the entire village; / Pushpa is caught in the encirclement of his ball-and-chain.*

**ANNOTATIONS:**

*This ghazal introduces the takhallus 'Pushpa' in the maqta — one of the collection's most intimate self-portraits. The 'golak bānh' (encirclement of the ball, or prison-ball-and-chain) is an unusually concrete image for the poet's sense of entrapment: social obligation, material poverty, and unrealised aspiration all compressed into a single object.*

*The imagery across the five shers moves from displacement (lost on a pathless road), through physical exhaustion (oil-press bullock), through emotional ambivalence (tears of joy and sorrow mixed), to the final encirclement of the maqta. This progression traces an arc from spatial disorientation to entrapment — a narrative within the ghazal's otherwise non-linear sher structure.*

*The bahr 2122 2122 2122 is the standard ḥazaj musaddas — the 'Dushyant metre' as it is known in the Hindi-Urdu tradition. Pushpa's use of this metre in a deeply personal rather than political ghazal demonstrates the form's versatility within the Videha tradition.*

## GHAZAL 8

Bahr: 2222222222 (all lines; two hemistich-final shorts taken as long variations) | Radif: 'karatai' (they do/will do) | Shers: 6

**MAITHILI TEXT:**

खेत बेचि कऽ टाकाक ओरियान करतैत
माथ पर बेटी छैत कन्यादान करतैत

जे रातिमे पी कऽ केने छल हो-हल्ला
वैह भोरे नशा-मुक्ति अभियान करतैत

जकरा छैत नइ बाँचल जोत एको धूर
तकरा बाढ़ि-रौदी की नुकसान करतैत

जे अपने कात भऽ बैसि गेल अछोप बिन
ओकरा बारीक किए अपमान करतैत

ओ नेता छैत सत्ताकेर बड्डु भूखल
बाँटि कऽ देश हिन्दु आ मुसलमान करतैत

आइ पार्थक जयघोष पर नाचैत दुनियाँ
समय राधेयक सेहो गुणगान करतैत □

**ENGLISH TRANSLATION:**

*Selling the field to arrange money; / A daughter on their head, and they will give her away in marriage. // The one who drank and raised a commotion at night / Will be running anti-addiction campaigns in the morning. // The one who has not even a clod of land left / — what loss can flood or drought do to them? // The one who silently withdrew and sat outside / — why should anyone bother to humiliate them? // That leader is very hungry for power; / He will divide the country into Hindu and Muslim. // Today the world dances to the victor's victory-cry; / Even Rādheya's [Karṇa's] time will come for singing his praises.*

**ANNOTATIONS:**

*This is Pushpa's most ambitious political ghazal — six shers covering farmer distress (sher 1), political hypocrisy (sher 2), the poor's exclusion from even the discourse of loss (sher 3), the erasure of the politically excluded (sher 4), communal politics (sher 5), and the ultimate reversal (sher 6).*

*Sher 6's reference to Rādheya (Karṇa's name as son of Radha, used in the Mahābhārata) is the collection's most literary allusion. Karṇa is the paradigmatic figure of the underprivileged hero — born to a lower-caste mother, denied recognition throughout his life, but ultimately honoured. The sher suggests that the marginalised (Rādheya) will eventually receive their recognition — a hope or a sarcasm depending on the reader's ironic register.*

*The grammatical structure of the radif 'karatai' (third person present-future) gives this ghazal a uniquely distanced, observational quality: the speaker watches and reports rather than directly addressing the actors. This positions the poet as witness — a formal choice with epistemological significance (the reliable narrator of social reality, as required by Navya-Nyāya's conditions for valid śabda-pramāṇa).*

## GHAZAL 9

Bahr: 2222222222222 (all lines; two hemistich-final shorts taken as long variations) | Radif: 'ī kon gāma chai' (what village is this?) | Shers: 5

**MAITHILI TEXT:**

भाषा भिन्ने भिन्न बजैत छैत ई कोन गाम छैत

केओ केकरो नै चिन्हैत छैत ई कोन गाम छैत

नै तरुआ तिलकोर नै दही चूड़ा गमिक रहल
गन्ध चाउमिनकेर अबैत छैत ई कोन गाम छैत

नै सोहर नै लगनी आ छैत नै नचारीक धुन
सगरो मात्र डीजे बजैत छैत ई कोन गाम छैत

बूढ़ माए बापकेँ कोन बेटा रखतै संगे
धुर! सभ सबहक मुँह तकैत छैत ई कोन गाम छैत

सून छैत दलान आ भकोभम्म भेल आँगन घर
चिढ़ कऽ सोफा कुकुर हँसैत छैत ई कोन गाम छैत □

**ENGLISH TRANSLATION:**

*Different languages spoken differently; no one recognises anyone — what village is this? // No fried taros, no tilkor greens, no smell of curd-rice remaining; only the aroma of Chinese noodles drifting — what village is this? // No Sohara birth-song, no Lagani wedding-song, no Nācārī devotional tune; only DJ music playing everywhere — what village is this? // What son will keep his old mother and father with him? Everyone just watches everyone else's face — what village is this? // The outer hall is empty, the courtyard desolate; a dog perches cross on the sofa, laughing — what village is this?*

**ANNOTATIONS:**

*This is Pushpa's finest ghazal and one of the strongest in the Videha Maithili tradition. Its five shers build a cumulative elegy for the cultural identity of the Mithila village through successive observations of specific loss: linguistic community, food culture, musical tradition, family bonds, and domestic space.*

*The Sohara and Laganī of Sher 3 are exactly the genres identified as endangered by Hriday Narayan Jha in his Videha Sadeha 1 essay 'Luptraprāya Maithilī Lokagīta'. Pushpa's ghazal and Jha's documentary essay are thus two parts of the same cultural testimony — the essay catalogues what is being lost, the ghazal grieves it in the living voice of the community.*

*The final image — 'ciṛha kaṣa sopā kukura haṃsaita chai' (a dog perches cross on the sofa, laughing) — is the collection's most memorable. The domestic space (sofa, outer hall, courtyard) has been abandoned by humans and occupied by an animal whose laughter (the contemptuous 'haṃsaita') comments ironically on the human abandonment. The dog's laughter is the village laughing at itself.*

*Radif as dhvani: The six-word radif 'ī kon gāma chai?' (what village is this?) is not merely a formal refrain but the poem's entire thematic question enacted at the formal level. The question cannot be answered: each sher adds evidence of dissolution without providing an alternative identity. The refrain's unanswerability IS the poem's meaning.*

## GHAZAL 10

Bahr: 22222222222222 (all lines; two hemistich-final shorts taken as long variations) | Radif: 'ker' (of/for) | Shers: 5 | Takhallus: Pushpa

**MAITHILI TEXT:**

दीप सभटा मिझा गेलैत तोहर मिलनक आस केर
तैयो भिर कऽ रखने छी टाड़ा अपन विश्वास केर

फूँकैत रहैत जे हेमिन धरि शंख जनवादी भेल
आइ ओ नटुआ भेल छैत सोझामे किछु खास केर

नव रहैत व्यापार हमर सुगन्धकेर शिकारी रही
बूझि गुलाब चूमि लेलौं तेँ ठोर हम पलास केर

जे सोझा साष्टांग करैत पान करैत चरणोदककेँ
पीठ पाछू ओ गाबैत खिस्सा हमर उपहास केर

भेँट अन्तिम कऽ ले आबो प्राण छुटि जेतैक हमर
जा रहल पुष्प साड़ा सपना लेने रिनवास केर □

**ENGLISH TRANSLATION:**

*All the lamps have been extinguished of hope for meeting you; / Yet I cling tightly to the rope of my own faith. // The one who kept blowing the populist conch all this time / Has today become a dancer in someone important's court. // Our business was always hunting for fragrance; / Thinking it was a rose, I kissed a palāś flower's lips. // The one who bows in prostration before me and drinks from my feet; / Behind my back the same one sings the story of my ridicule. // Come, take your last meeting before my life departs; / Pushpa is leaving, carrying all his dreams, for the place of debt-repayment.*

**ANNOTATIONS:**

*The maqta's 'rinivāsa ker' (for the place of debt-repayment/departure) is the collection's most metaphysically resonant ending. The takhallus verse positions Pushpa as someone leaving with 'all his dreams' intact — the dreams unrealised, but the act of leaving dignified rather than defeated. Rinivāsa (place of repaying debts) carries a double meaning: the Hindu concept of the place where one repays karmic debts (death/afterlife) and the practical sense of migrating to a place where one can repay financial debts.*

*Sher 3 — 'New was my trade, always hunting for fragrance; / Thinking it was a rose, I kissed the lips of a palāś flower' — is the collection's most beautiful nature-metaphor. The palāś (Flame of the Forest, Butea monosperma) blooms brilliantly orange-red and has no scent — a flower of appearance without fragrance. The sher encapsulates the ghazal's meditation on false promise and misplaced trust.*

*Sher 2 — 'The one who kept blowing the populist conch all this time / Has today become a dancer in someone important's court' — is a precise portrait of political apostasy: the progressive activist who becomes an establishment*

*functionary. 'Naṭuā' (dancer/performer in a patron's service) is the opposite of the committed artist — the one who performs for whoever pays.*

## II. GLOSSARY OF GHAZAL TECHNICAL TERMS

For readers approaching the Maithili ghazal tradition for the first time, the following glossary provides definitions of technical terms used throughout this anthology:

Bahr (बहर): The prosodic metre of a ghazal — the pattern of long (dīrgha/2) and short (laghu/1) syllables that must be maintained uniformly across all shers. In the Videha tradition, bahr is notated numerically.

Ghazal (गजल): A lyric poem of Persian-origin form consisting of independent two-line units (shers). All shers share the same metre (bahr), rhyme (radif+qāfiya), and the final sher (maqta) typically contains the poet's pen-name (takhallus).

Maqla (मतला): The opening sher of a ghazal, in which both lines carry the full radif and rhyme.

Maqta (मकता): The closing/final sher, containing the takhallus (pen-name).

Qāfiya (काफिया): The rhyme syllable immediately before the radif.

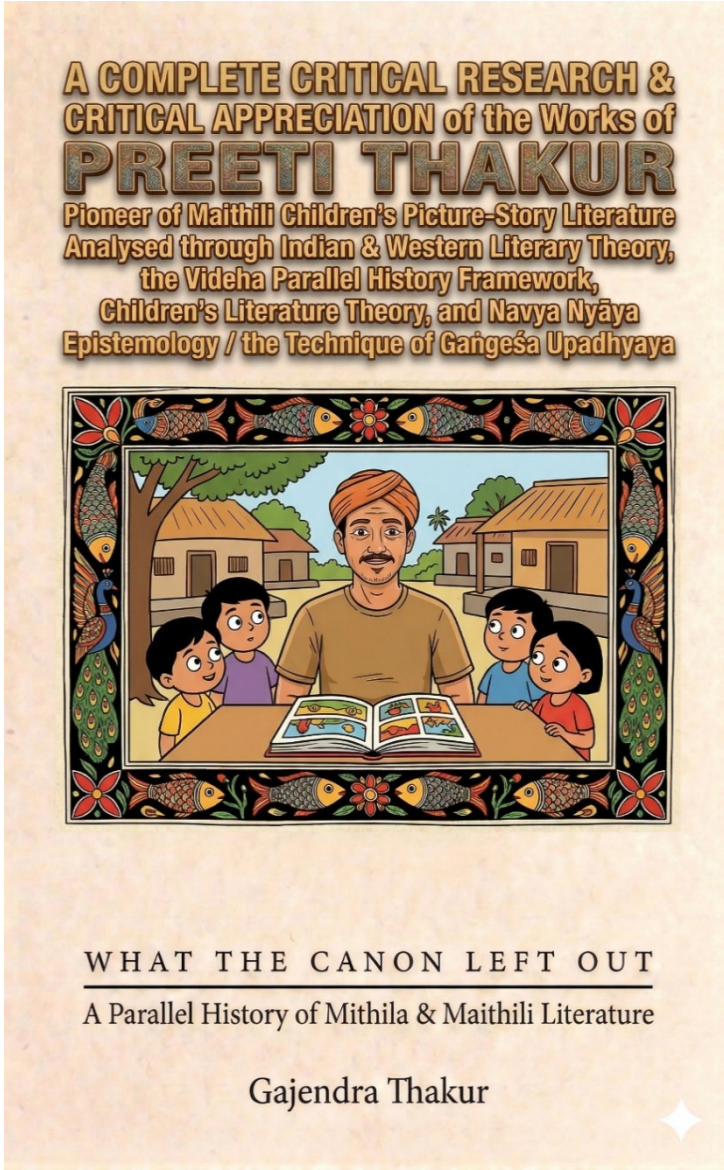
Radif (रदीफ़): The repeated word or phrase at the end of each sher — the refrain.

Sher (शेर): The individual two-line unit of a ghazal. Each sher should be semantically complete and independent.

Takhallus (तखल्लुस): The poet's pen-name, used in the maqta. Pradeep Pushpa's takhallus is 'Pushpa' (पुष्प).

Vārṇik bahr: A bahr based on syllable-counting (without strict distinction of heavy/light) — simpler to learn and associated with the pedagogical early ghazals in the Videha tradition.

**LESSON 057 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**



# A COMPLETE CRITICAL RESEARCH & CRITICAL APPRECIATION

of the Works of **PREETI THAKUR**

*Pioneer of Maithili Children's Picture-Story Literature*

Analysed through Indian & Western Literary Theory,

the Videha Parallel History Framework,

Children's Literature Theory, and

Navya Nyāya Epistemology / the Technique of Gaṅgeśa Upadhyaya

PART I: INTRODUCTION AND BIOGRAPHICAL OVERVIEW

## 1.1 Who is Preeti Thakur?

Preeti Thakur (also spelled Priti Thakur, Prity Thakur) is a Mithila-based Maithili writer, illustrator, archivist, and cultural worker. She is unambiguously recognised by the critical consensus of the Videha movement as the first creator of picture-story books (chitrakatha) in the Maithili language, and the first full-time children's literature author in any modern sense of the term in Maithili. She is the spouse and literary partner of Gajendra Thakur, editor of Videha — the first and longest-running Maithili fortnightly e-journal (ISSN 2229-547X, since 2000/2004) published at www.videha.co.in.

Her contribution is simultaneously literary, archival, artistic, and civilisational. She illustrates her own picture stories, depicts folk heroes of Mithila who have been erased from mainstream Brahmin-centric literary historiography, and has, alongside Gajendra Thakur, compiled and catalogued 11,000 palm-leaf Panji (genealogical) inscriptions in the Tirhuta script, constituting the largest archival operation in Mithila's recorded history.

## 1.2 The Literary and Cultural Ecology

Maithili is an Indo-Aryan language spoken by approximately 35 million people in North Bihar (India) and the Terai of Nepal. Recognised in the Eighth Schedule of the Indian Constitution in 2003, it possesses a documented literary tradition running from at least the 8th century Buddhist Charyapadas. Despite its antiquity and the undisputed greatness of medieval court-poet Vidyapati Thakkurah (1350–1435), Maithili's modern literary establishment has been systematically controlled by Maithil Brahmin and Karna Kayastha elites, as documented exhaustively in Gajendra Thakur's A Parallel History of Mithila &

Maithili Literature (Videha, 2019–present) and confirmed by RTI data gathered by Vinit Utpal and Ashish Anchinhar (2011–14).

It is within this structurally unequal literary field that Preeti Thakur carves out an entirely new genre — the Maithili chitrakatha (picture-story book) — while simultaneously working to preserve subaltern folk heroes and interstitial histories. Her emergence is not a provincial literary footnote but a civilisational intervention.

## 1.3 Preeti Thakur: Key Firsts in Maithili Literature

> These "firsts" are documented in multiple sources, including the testimony collected in Preeti Karan Setu Banhal — Redefining Maithili (Ed. Ashish Anchinhar, ISBN 978-93-5810-458-5) and Setusham: Vibrant Maithili (2nd Volume).

- First creator and illustrator of a Maithili picture-story book: In 2002, she first translated the picture book Chhot Aur Baigh into Maithili (a genre-opening experiment). In 2008, she published her first wholly original Maithili chitrakatha: Gonu Jha Aan Maithili Chitrakatha (Shruti Publication, Delhi).
- First full-time children's literature author in Maithili: As documented in both critical volumes above. Before Preeti Thakur, no Maithili writer was working exclusively in the children's picture-book genre.
- First Maithili illustrator to depict suppressed folk heroes: Including Reshma-Chuharmal, Bhagata Jyoti Panjiyar, Mahua Ghatwarin, Chhechhan Maharaj — figures absent from the mainstream Brahmin canon but living in the oral memory of Mithila's subaltern communities.
- Co-compiler of 11,000 Palm-Leaf Panji Inscriptions: As archival contributor alongside Gajendra Thakur and Nagendra Kumar Jha (Panjikar Vidyanand Jha) — an unprecedented documentary achievement.
- Creator of Vidyapatik Purusha Pariksha (2012, 2022): A children's illustrated book on Vidyapati Thakkurah's Sanskrit prose classic — the first children's adaptation of this 14th-century Avahatta work in Maithili.

PART II: ANNOTATED BIBLIOGRAPHY OF WORKS

## 2.1 Gonu Jha Aan Maithili Chitrakatha (2008)

Publisher: Shruti Publication, 8/21, Ground Floor, New Rajendra Nagar, New Delhi – 110008. ISBN 978-93-80538-13-6. Narrated by Gajendra Thakur. Illustrated by Preeti Thakur. Price: Rs. 100 / US $80 (libraries). 1st Edition 2009 (Maithili language).

**Contents:** Sixteen stories compiled through picture-story medium. Nine stories feature Gonu Jha (the famous Maithili wit, analogous to Birbal of the Mughal court), and seven feature folk and historical figures: Reshma-Chuharmal, Naika-Banijara, Bhagata Jyoti Panjiyar, Mahua Ghatwarin, Raja Salhes, Chhechhan Maharaj, and Kalidasa's connection with Mithila.

The nine Gonu Jha stories are: Gonu Jha Aan Maa Durga; Gonu Aan Swarg; Gonu Aan Swarn Chor; Gonu Jha Aan Bilarri; Gonu Jha Ka Duta Barad; Gonu Jha Ka Mahis; Gonu Jha Ki Ashrafi; Gonu Jha Aan Kar Adhikari Ki Darhi; Gonu Jha Ki Maay.

The supplementary historical folk stories are: Reshma Chuharmal; Naika Banijara; Bhagata Jyoti Panjiyar; Mahua Ghatwarin; Raja Salhes; Chhechhan Maharaj; Raja Salhes Aan Kalidas.

*"Seeing Preeti Thakur's Maithili picture story book on Gonu Jha, I was amazed. Initially, I thought of it as comics for Maithili children, but as I started reading, I became immersed in it. Much substance in a small vessel. It's wonderful how she has condensed the vast world of Maithili folk tales like Shiva's matted hair." — Dr. Shefalika Verma, in Preeti Karan Setu Banhal (Videha Issue 74, 15 January 2011)*

## 2.2 Maithili Chitrakatha (2009)

Second original collection. 1st Edition 2009. Published by Shruti Publication, New Delhi. ISBN 978-93-80538-13-6. Illustrated by Preeti Thakur. Contents: Moti Dai; Raja Salhes; Bodhi-Kayastha; Bahura Godhin Natua Dayal; Amta Gharen; Dina Bhadri; Jhalim Singh; Naika Banijara; Raghuni Marrar; Vidyapati Ki Aayu Avasan.

All ten stories are grounded in the folk memory and oral tradition of Mithila, featuring characters from across caste and class lines, with particular attention to artisan, lower-caste, and female figures largely absent from official Maithili literary canons. The story of Moti Dai, for example, opens with a village scene depicting a barren woman's grief in a community of washermen — a social stratum rarely centred in Maithili literature.

## 2.3 Mithilak Lokdevata

This larger collection (available in the Videha archive) contains a combined and expanded version of the two chitrakatha collections, with a preface (katha aa kalpana) that theorises the genre of Maithili chitrakatha itself. The preface is written in Maithili and explains the art of storytelling (katha kahba), the

combination of verbal and visual imagination (kalpana), and the pedagogical vision behind the books: to nurture children's creativity (kalpanashilata) by letting them choose which story episode to illustrate, which colour to fill, and which dialogue to supply — a genuinely constructivist pedagogical vision.

*"Stories have been told in our tradition. Grandmothers told stories to all of us — stories from royal courts, stories of Gonu Jha — and we were amazed. In this collection, we have placed twelve illustrated stories and six wordless stories... The method of telling a story and the sequential illustrated imagination are given here." — Preeti Thakur, Preface to Mithilak Lokdevata (trans. from Maithili)*

## 2.4 Vidyapatik Purusha Pariksha (2012, 2022)

A children's illustrated book by Preeti Thakur, published via Videha (www.videha.co.in), ISSN 2229-547X. First edition 2012, revised 2022. Based on the Sanskrit and Avahatta prose classic Purusha Pariksha by Vidyapati Thakkurah (1350–1435), which itself contains 107 tales of ethical and practical wisdom drawn from pan-Indian didactic traditions. Preeti Thakur adapts this medieval text for a child audience, providing illustrations and simplified narrative framing in Maithili.

The book is doubly significant: it engages with the Videha parallel-history project's key scholarly intervention regarding the two Vidyapatis (the pre-Jyotirishwar Adi Kavi of the democratic tradition vs. the Sanskrit/Avahatta Thakkurah, 1350–1435), and it democratises a text that had previously circulated only in Sanskrit-literate scholarly circles. For Preeti Thakur, translating a 14th-century didactic prose classic for children enacts the same democratising impulse as her chitrakatha series.

## 2.5 Mithilak Lokdevta (Folk Deities of Mithila)

Reviewed by Shiv Kumar Jha 'Tillu' in Preeti Karan Setu Banhal. This work extends Preeti Thakur's attention from folk heroes to folk religion — specifically to the non-Brahmin deity-figures venerated by Mithila's lower-caste and artisan communities. The inclusion of this title in the critical volumes situates it within the Videha movement's broader project of recovering Dalit and subaltern spiritual traditions alongside literary ones.

### 2.6 Archival Contribution: 11,000 Palm-Leaf Panji Inscriptions

Compiled, Scanned & Catalogued by Preeti Thakur (with Gajendra Thakur, Nagendra Kumar Jha, and Panjikar Vidyanand Jha). Published in Volumes I–XXII via Videha archive. The Panji are genealogical records of the Maithil community, inscribed in Tirhuta (Mithilakshar) script on palm leaves, containing data running from approximately 450 CE to 2009 CE. Preeti Thakur's role in physically cataloguing and scanning 11,000 such inscriptions represents a form of archival and scholarly labour rarely credited in mainstream literary biography but central to the Videha counter-archive.

## PART III: CRITICAL RECEPTION AND TESTIMONIALS

### 3.1 Dr. Shefalika Verma — "Preeti Thakur's Gonu Jha and Other Maithili Picture Stories"

(Published in Videha Issue 74, 15 January 2011; reprinted in Preeti Karan Setu Banhal)

Shefalika Verma, a prominent Maithili critic and novelist, opens her review with a meditation on gender and literary criticism: "In every language, there are some creators, whether women or men, who, due to their extraordinary talent, stand out distinctly from the rest. It is a different matter that the critical class often relegates women's writing to a corner of history's pages." She then pivots to a form of critical surprise at Preeti Thakur's achievement: the richness of content within the economical form of the children's picture-story.

> Critical note: Verma's review performs a dual function. It acknowledges Preeti Thakur's achievement while situating it within a feminist critique of Maithili literary criticism's systematic marginalisation of women writers — a structural observation entirely consonant with the Videha parallel-history framework.

Verma observes that the book revives for readers the folk characters they had only heard names of: Gonu Jha, Raja Salhes, Mahua Ghatwarin, Chhechhan Maharaj — and that through picture-story medium these figures become "recognisable ideals of all sections of society." She closes with a programmatic suggestion: that the legends of the Kosi river — its mythic marriage to Singheshwar Baba — should similarly be captured in the chitrakatha format.

### 3.2 Prof. Veena Thakur — “Gonu Jha and Other Maithili Picture Stories”

(Reprinted in Preeti Karan Setu Banhal)

Veena Thakur approaches the book from the standpoint of cultural transmission: “Behavior received through tradition can be called culture. Qualities like love, sacrifice, kindness, compassion, empathy, etc.” She argues that the chitrakatha format serves to transmit these cultural values across the generational rupture caused by modernisation. Like Verma, she stresses the gallery of folk characters as a form of cultural memory-work.

### 3.3 Dr. Raman Jha — ‘Gonu Jha Aan Maithili Chitrakatha’ and ‘Maithili Chitrakatha’

(Reprinted in Preeti Karan Setu Banhal; also compiled in Parijat Manjari)

Dr. Raman Jha contextualises Preeti Thakur's innovation within the oral tradition of Mithila: “The tradition of telling and listening to tales and fables has been going on in Mithila since ancient times. Elderly women folk tell various kinds of stories to young children at bedtime, which are entertaining as well as instructive and educational.” He argues that Preeti Thakur's achievement is to have bridged the oral and written, the visual and verbal, in a manner that had not previously been attempted in Maithili.

He also makes a pointed observation about the comparative inadequacy of Maithili children's literature before 2008: despite being in the Eighth Schedule of the Indian Constitution, certain categories of composition had remained “untouched in Maithili, a language of a premier language group,” and that he was “surprised and amazed: how did a woman from our society get focused on this new subject?”

### 3.4 Shiv Kumar Jha ‘Tillu’ — Multiple Reviews

(Three pieces: on Gonu Jha Aan Maithili Chitrakatha; on Maithili Chitrakatha; on Mithilak Lokdevta)

Tillu situates the publication of both chitrakatha volumes in 2008–09 as “a revolutionary period for the development of children's literature in Maithili.” He notes that before Preeti Thakur's books, the same period saw the award-winning E Bhetal Ta Ki Bhetal by Taranand Viyogi (which received the Sahitya Akademi's Bal Sahitya Puraskar), and argues that had the Akademi's award

been established earlier, Preeti Thakur's chitrakatha would have had prior claim.

### 3.5 Dhirendra Kumar — “A Glance at Both of Preeti Thakur's Picture Story Books”

Dhirendra Kumar writes from a reader-response position: “Literature becomes complete only when it is written in all genres and the compositions are mature. In my view, Preeti Thakur's compositions in the picture story genre... are successful compositions.” He specifically praises her for “attempting to enrich the picture story genre of Maithili, which is negligible, by giving written form to the stories preserved in people's mouths in Maithili's heritage.”

### 3.6 Durganand Mandal — “Beautiful Picture Stories for Children”

Mandal's review, included in the critical volume, stresses the accessibility and child-centredness of Preeti Thakur's work. He underscores the cultural-retrieval function of the folk-hero stories: figures like Reshma-Chuharmal and Mahua Ghatwarin, whose stories were fading from living memory, are preserved in Preeti Thakur's format in ways that “attract children but [also] people of all ages.”

### 3.7 Munni Kamat — “A Proficient Writer of the Child's Mind”

(In Setusham: Vibrant Maithili, Volume 2)

*"For any creation, the first churning, the first foundation, and the first brick standing on it are of great importance. Because any skyscraper built afterwards imitates only that. In Maithili children's literature, it is Mrs. Preeti Thakur who, along with the first conceptualization of the picture story, also gave it the form of a book... Building children's literature is a bit more difficult than building literature. To create children's literature, the writer first has to become a child of that age; only then is the exchange of emotions possible." — Munni Kamat*

### 3.8 Ira Mallick — “Preeti Thakur's Contribution to Maithili Picture Stories”

(In Setusham: Vibrant Maithili, Volume 2. Ira Mallick is also Smtā Editor of the ‘Stri Kona’ [Women's Corner] section of Videha)

Mallick's piece extends the feminist critical dimension of the reception, situating Preeti Thakur's contribution within the broader women's tradition in Maithili that the Videha parallel history has been recovering: alongside Vibha Rani, Kamini Kamayani, Susmita Pathak, Panna Jha, Kalpana Jha, and Premlata Mishra Prem. Mallick argues that Preeti Thakur's chitrakatha series is not simply a contribution to children's literature but to the feminist counter-canon of Maithili.

### 3.9 Ashish Anchinhar — "The Early History of Maithili Picture Stories (2002–2016)"

(In Preeti Karan Setu Banhal; Anchinhar is editor of both critical volumes)

Anchinhar provides the most systematic historical account of the Maithili chitrakatha genre. He documents that Preeti Thakur's 2002 translation of Chhot Aur Baigh represents the genre's first appearance in Maithili, that her 2008 Gonu Jha Aan Maithili Chitrakatha is the first wholly original Maithili picture-story book, and that her work created the conditions for subsequent children's literature production in the language. He notes that four reviews of the first critical volume (Preeti Karan Setu Banhal) were published together in Videha Issue 398 (July 15, 2024).

## PART IV: THEORETICAL FRAMEWORKS AND CRITICAL ANALYSIS

### 4.1 The Videha Parallel History Framework

Gajendra Thakur's A Parallel History of Mithila & Maithili Literature (Videha, 2019–present, Parts 1–46+) constitutes the theoretical and historiographical framework within which Preeti Thakur's work must be understood. Its core argument is that the mainstream Maithili literary historiography, as curated by the Sahitya Akademi since 1965, has systematically promoted an upper-caste (predominantly Maithil Brahmin) canon while suppressing democratic, folk, Dalit, feminist, and Nepal-side traditions.

The framework operates on nine analytical layers: (1) Buddhist Charyapada foundations; (2) the two Vidyapatis; (3) the suppressed Gangesh Upadhyaya; (4) colonial-era protest poetry; (5) Harimohan Jha's exclusion; (6) the living masters (Rajdeo Mandal, Bechan Thakur, Jagdish Prasad Mandal); (7) RTI

exposure of Sahitya Akademi nepotism; (8) Nepal-side Maithili; (9) the Videha digital counter-archive.

Within this schema, Preeti Thakur occupies a defined structural position in layer (9) — the digital counter-archive — and simultaneously enacts layers (1) and (3) by recovering folk and subaltern figures (Reshma-Chuharmal, Mahua Ghatwarin, etc.) who belong to the suppressed oral canon, and layer (6) by working as a living creative practitioner outside the official awards infrastructure.

> The Parallel History Framework insists that literary value is not intrinsic but relational: a text's meaning is shaped by the institutional field that either recognises or suppresses it. Preeti Thakur's work acquires its critical weight partly because it was created outside and against the institutional apparatus that had kept Maithili children's literature at zero.

## 4.2 Indian Literary Theory: Rasa, Dhvani, and Chitrakatha

### *4.2.1 Rasa Theory (Bharata Muni, Natyashastra; Abhinavagupta, Abhinavabharati)*

Classical Sanskrit rasa theory holds that literary art produces rasa — aesthetic emotion or “relish” — in the sensitive reader (sahridaya) through the conjunction of vibhava (determinants), anubhava (consequents), and vyabhichari bhava (transient emotional states). Bharata Muni identifies eight primary rasas; Abhinavagupta adds shanta (serenity) as a ninth.

Preeti Thakur's chitrakatha series is primarily oriented toward two rasas: hasya (comic delight) in the Gonu Jha stories, and karuna (pathos/compassion) in the folk-hero narratives. The Gonu Jha cycle operates through the classic structure of wit overcoming power — a structure that produces hasya while also engaging adbhuta (wonder) as the trickster repeatedly astonishes those in authority. The folk-hero stories, particularly the Reshma-Chuharmal narrative and the Mahua Ghatwarin story, are suffused with karuna shaded by vira (heroic emotion) as characters navigate social oppression.

Abhinavagupta's concept of sadharanikarana (universalisation) is particularly relevant: the chitrakatha format does not merely tell a local story but lifts the characters into a register of universal recognition, accessible to child and adult reader alike. The aesthetic distance created by the visual medium (pictures rather than unmediated text) enables the sadharanikarana process.

### *4.2.2 Dhvani Theory (Anandavardhana, Dhvanyaloka)*

Anandavardhana's dhvani (resonance/suggestion) theory holds that the highest form of literary expression operates through suggestion rather than direct statement. The implied or resonant meaning (dhvani or vyangya) is aesthetically superior to the directly expressed (vacyartha). In Preeti Thakur's chitrakatha, the visual image operates precisely as dhvani does in classical poetry: the picture does not illustrate a scene so much as suggest a world beyond itself. The drawing of a folk hero marginalised from the mainstream literary record carries an implied critique of that marginalisation without ever stating it.

This resonance-structure is especially operative in Vidyapatik Purusha Pariksha, where the adaptation of a 14th-century Sanskrit didactic text for a Maithili-language children's audience enacts a dhvani of cultural continuity and democratic access: the suggestion is that this heritage belongs to all children, not only to those educated in Sanskrit.

### *4.2.3 Vakrokti Theory (Kuntaka, Vakroktijivita)*

Kuntaka's vakrokti (deviant or oblique expression) theory argues that literary art is characterised by a deviation from the ordinary use of language — an obliqueness that creates beauty and meaning. Applied to Preeti Thakur, the very act of translating oral folk-narrative into a visual-verbal medium is a form of vakrokti: the story is told obliquely, through the indirection of image, colour, and minimal text, rather than through direct narrative exposition. This obliqueness is not a deficiency but, in Kuntaka's terms, the very source of its aesthetic power.

## 4.3 Western Literary Theory

### *4.3.1 Feminist Literary Criticism (Elaine Showalter, Sandra Gilbert & Susan Gubar)*

Elaine Showalter's gynocriticism — the study of women as writers, focusing on the female literary tradition — is directly applicable to Preeti Thakur's situation. Showalter identifies three phases in women's literary history: the Feminine phase (imitation of dominant tradition), the Feminist phase (protest and advocacy), and the Female phase (self-discovery and autonomous tradition-building). Preeti Thakur operates unambiguously in the Female phase: she does not imitate the Brahmin male literary mainstream of Maithili, nor does she primarily protest it (though her recovery of subaltern folk heroes

carries an implicit protest). She constructs a new genre, a new audience (children), and a new critical-visual language.

Gilbert and Gubar's concept of the “madwoman in the attic” — the repressed female creative energy that must find oblique expression in a male-dominated literary field — finds its counterpart in the Maithili context in the documented absence of women writers from Sahitya Akademi awards and assignments (confirmed by RTI data). Preeti Thakur's creative energy, unable to find official recognition, flows into the Videha counter-archive — a digital “attic” that is in fact more open and more widely read than the official publications it subverts.

### *4.3.2 Postcolonial Theory (Homi Bhabha, Gayatri Spivak)*

Homi Bhabha's concept of the “third space” — the ambivalent, hybrid cultural space produced by colonial encounter — is applicable to the Maithili chitrakatha as a genre. The picture-story book is itself a “third space” between oral tradition (the grandmother's bedtime story) and the imported print-culture format (the modern comic/graphic narrative). Preeti Thakur occupies this third space productively, neither simply reproducing Western graphic novel conventions nor merely transcribing oral tradition, but creating a hybrid form adequate to Maithili culture.

Gayatri Spivak's question “Can the subaltern speak?” resonates with particular force in the context of Preeti Thakur's recovery of non-Brahmin folk heroes. Reshma-Chuharmal, whose story crosses caste lines (a Dugdhvanshi Dusadh hero and a Purnia Bhumihar Brahmin heroine), or Mahua Ghatwarin, whose story was fading from even oral memory — these figures are the subaltern given visual and narrative form. In Spivak's terms, Preeti Thakur performs the impossible but necessary act of making the subaltern speak without herself claiming to speak for them: the picture-story format maintains the folk hero's own cultural logic.

### *4.3.3 Reader-Response Theory (Wolfgang Iser, Hans Robert Jauss)*

Wolfgang Iser's theory of the “implied reader” and the “indeterminacy” of the literary text is especially illuminating for the chitrakatha form. Iser argues that literary texts are full of “gaps” and “blanks” that the reader must fill through imaginative participation. In Preeti Thakur's picture stories, this gap-filling is made literal and pedagogically intentional: the preface to PrityThakur-3 explicitly describes how children are invited to choose which episode to illustrate, which colour to apply, which dialogue to supply. Iser's implied reader is here made the actual, active, constructing child-reader.

Hans Robert Jauss's concept of the “horizon of expectations” — the cultural and aesthetic expectations a reader brings to a text, which the text may confirm, expand, or subvert — helps explain the critical surprise registered by reviewers like Raman Jha and Shefalika Verma. Their surprise at finding “much substance in a small vessel” indicates that Preeti Thakur's chitrakatha exceeded the horizon of expectations associated with the children's book: it was read as serious literature precisely because it exceeded the genre's expected range.

### *4.3.4 Mikhail Bakhtin: Dialogism, Heteroglossia, and Carnivalesque*

Bakhtin's concept of the carnivalesque — the festive, popular-cultural inversion of hierarchies and authorities — is directly operative in the Gonu Jha cycle. Gonu Jha is himself a carnivalesque figure: a court jester who repeatedly outsmarts those in power, whose wit exposes the pretensions of Brahmins, tax officials, and even divine authority. Bakhtin argues that carnival laughter is not merely comic but liberatory, temporarily suspending the social order that normally enforces hierarchy. In Mithila, Gonu Jha stories have always served this function in oral culture; Preeti Thakur's chitrakatha extends this carnivalesque energy into the space of the children's book, giving the next generation access to the culture's most subversive comic tradition.

Bakhtin's heteroglossia — the co-presence of multiple social voices and registers in a text — is also evident in Preeti Thakur's selection of folk heroes from across the social spectrum. The chitrakatha does not speak in one voice but in many: the voice of the Dusadh community (Reshma-Chuharmal), the voice of the fishing and boatmen castes (Mahua Ghatwarin), the voice of the barber caste (Thakur, mentioned in Raman Jha's review), alongside the wit-tradition associated with the Brahmin court jester.

## 4.4 Theories of Children's Literature

### *4.4.1 The Developmental Framework (Jean Piaget, L. S. Vygotsky)*

Piaget's theory of cognitive development identifies distinct stages: sensorimotor (0–2), preoperational (2–7), concrete operational (7–11), and formal operational (12+). Preeti Thakur's chitrakatha are primarily aimed at the preoperational and concrete operational stages: the picture-story format is ideally suited to the preoperational child's thinking in images and narratives rather than abstract concepts. The minimal text and dominant visual register of the chitrakatha accommodates the preoperational child's iconic cognition.

Vygotsky's concept of the Zone of Proximal Development (ZPD) — the space between what a child can do independently and what they can do with guidance — is enacted by the chitrakatha's design. The preface to PrityThakur-3 explicitly describes a practice of guided co-creation: adult and child work together on the stories, the child choosing the colouring and dialogue while the adult provides the narrative scaffold. This is Vygotskyan scaffolding in explicit pedagogical action.

### *4.4.2 Roderick McGillis and the Ideology of Children's Literature*

Roderick McGillis (The Nimble Reader, 1996) argues that children's literature is never politically neutral but always ideologically laden — teaching children what to value, whom to trust, what kind of person to become. Preeti Thakur's chitrakatha are ideologically counter-hegemonic: against the Brahmin-centric ideological field of mainstream Maithili literature, they present folk heroes from Dusadh, fishing, and artisan communities as the protagonists of cultural memory and moral exemplarity. The ideology encoded is not of caste supremacy but of folk dignity and cross-caste solidarity.

### *4.4.3 Maria Nikolajeva on Visual-Verbal Dynamics*

Maria Nikolajeva and Carole Scott (How Picturebooks Work, 2001) develop a taxonomy of the relationships between verbal text and image in picture books: symmetrical (image and text convey the same information), complementary (each adds what the other lacks), enhancing, counterpointing, and contradictory. Preeti Thakur's chitrakatha largely work through the complementary mode: the minimal verbal text (often a few lines of dialogue or caption) adds information not contained in the image, while the image embodies the emotional and social texture that the text does not attempt to describe. This is a sophisticated distribution of labour between the two semiotic channels.

### *4.4.4 The Oral Tradition and Children's Literature*

Walter Ong's Orality and Literacy (1982) argues that oral cultures think and communicate in fundamentally different ways from literate cultures, privileging aggregative rather than analytic, situational rather than abstract, participatory rather than distanced structures. Preeti Thakur's chitrakatha are a form of what Ong would call “secondary orality”: they are grounded in the oral folk tradition of Mithila (the grandmother's bedtime stories, the village tales of Gonu Jha) but transmit that tradition through the literate medium of the printed

book. This is the generic and cultural transition that makes the chitrakatha historically significant.

## 4.5 Navya Nyāya Epistemology: The Technique of Gaṅgeśa Upadhyaya

### *4.5.1 Gangesh Upadhyaya and Tattvachintamani*

Gangesh Upadhyaya (Gangesa, c. 13th century CE, Darbhanga, Mithila) is the founder of the Navya Nyāya (New Logic) school of Indian philosophy. His magnum opus, the Tattvachintamani (Jewel of Reflection on the True Nature of Things), is one of the most technically rigorous works of epistemological and logical analysis in any philosophical tradition, developing a highly precise formal language for analysing knowledge, inference, and verbal testimony (sabda).

The Videha Parallel History makes a specific and politically charged intervention regarding Gangesh: original Panji (genealogical) manuscripts demonstrate that he was born of an inter-caste union (his mother was from a leather-tanning, i.e., Charmkarini, caste) and that his father had already died when he was born. This fact was suppressed by the scholar Ramanath Jha and the Sahitya Akademi's 2016 monograph on Gangesh perpetuated the suppression. The recovery of Gangesh's actual biography is part of the Videha movement's broader effort to deconstruct Brahmin cultural hegemony in Mithila.

### *4.5.2 Applying Navya Nyāya Epistemological Categories to Preeti Thakur's Work*

Navya Nyāya develops a highly technical vocabulary for analysing the structure of knowledge claims. Three categories are particularly useful for literary criticism:

- Vyapti (pervasion/invariable concomitance): The logical relationship of necessary connection between two properties, analogous to a universal law. In the context of Preeti Thakur's work: the invariable concomitance between the chitrakatha format and the democratisation of cultural heritage. Wherever the chitrakatha appears in Maithili, cultural accessibility to previously marginalised children and communities follows necessarily.
- Paksha, Sadhya, Hetu (Subject, Predicate, Reason in inference): The structure of Nyāya inference applied to the critical claim: Preeti Thakur's chitrakatha (paksha) achieves cultural democratisation (sadhya) because it

presents subaltern folk heroes in an accessible visual-verbal format (hetu), given that such presentation is invariably connected with cultural democratisation (vyapti).

- Sabda pramana (verbal testimony as a source of knowledge): In Nyāya, verbal testimony from an authorised speaker (apta) is a valid source of knowledge. The oral folk tradition preserved in Mithila's village communities constitutes sabda pramana that Preeti Thakur's chitrakatha renders accessible in written/visual form. The grandmothers' bedtime stories are the original apta; the chitrakatha is their authorised transcription.

### *4.5.3 The Epistemological Politics of the Panji Archive*

The Panji — the genealogical inscription system that Preeti Thakur helped compile and catalogue — is itself a site of epistemological contest. For centuries, the Panji was controlled by hereditary Panjikars (genealogists) who used it to enforce Brahmin endogamy and casteism. The Videha project's digitisation of 11,000 palm-leaf Panji inscriptions in Volumes I–XXII is an epistemological intervention: it makes public knowledge that was controlled as private knowledge by a caste guild. In Nyāya terms, it transforms inaccessible agama (traditional authoritative testimony) into publicly accessible pratyaksha (direct perception/verifiable data).

Crucially, the Panji evidence also reveals inter-caste marriages — approximately 100 documented inter-caste unions — including the origin of Gangesh Upadhyaya himself. This transforms the Panji from an instrument of caste closure into evidence of caste intermixture — a reversal of epistemological function that has direct relevance to the ideological politics of Preeti Thakur's folk-hero stories, which similarly celebrate cross-caste humanity.

# PART V: THEMATIC ANALYSIS OF PREETI THAKUR'S LITERARY CORPUS

## 5.1 The Folk Hero as Counter-Canon

The most consistent thematic movement in Preeti Thakur's chitrakatha is the elevation of folk heroes from Mithila's oral tradition to the status of literary characters worthy of a permanent text. This movement is simultaneously aesthetic and political: aesthetic because it creates new literary subjects and new visual iconographies; political because it challenges the canon of Brahmin court culture that has dominated Maithili literary history.

Gonu Jha is the most prominent example: a figure of wit and practical intelligence who occupies in Mithila's collective imagination the position that Birbal occupies in Mughal cultural memory, but who has been relegated to a minor position in official Maithili literary historiography dominated by the high-Sanskrit Vidyapati tradition. Preeti Thakur restores Gonu Jha to his cultural centrality by making him the subject of nine consecutive picture-stories, each enacting the carnivalesque logic of wit defeating power.

More politically charged is her treatment of Reshma-Chuharmal: a cross-caste love story between a Dugdhvanshi Dusadh man and a Bhumihar Brahmin woman, “the viewpoint of trampling love under the caste system of society is broken in this picture story” (Raman Jha). This is not simply a romantic narrative but a critique of the caste system embedded in a children's book — the same pedagogical space that dominant ideology has typically used to reproduce caste values.

## 5.2 Gender and the Maithili Children's Literary Space

As Shefalika Verma and Ira Mallick observe in their reviews, Preeti Thakur's entry into Maithili children's literature is itself a gender intervention. Women writers in Maithili have been systematically excluded from official literary infrastructure. Preeti Thakur does not seek entry into this official space but creates a new space: the chitrakatha for children, where she is simultaneously author, illustrator, and the first practitioner of the genre.

Several of her folk-hero stories centre women: Reshma in the cross-caste love narrative, Moti Dai in the story that opens the second collection, Mahua Ghatwarin whose story was in danger of disappearing entirely from collective

memory. These female folk protagonists are not secondary characters or object-lessons but full agents of their own narratives.

## 5.3 The Pedagogy of Imagination and Constructivist Learning

The preface to PrityThakur-3 reveals that Preeti Thakur's pedagogical vision is explicitly constructivist: children are invited not merely to receive the stories but to participate in their completion. The procedure described is: (1) adult reads the story; (2) child selects which episode to illustrate; (3) child fills in the colours; (4) child adds dialogue. This is not passive reception but active construction of meaning — precisely the Vygotskyan ZPD in action.

The preface also notes that “through this all the child's imaginative ability can increase, and at the same time imagination can become a literal reality” (trans. from Maithili). This is a sophisticated statement of the relationship between fictional world-making and cognitive development: imagination, exercised in the play-space of the chitrakatha, becomes a faculty for comprehending reality.

## 5.4 The Medieval-Modern Bridge: Vidyapatik Purusha Pariksha

The adaptation of Vidyapati Thakkurah's 14th-century Sanskrit prose classic for a Maithili children's audience performs a thematic operation of historical continuity: the child reading Preeti Thakur's version of the Purusha Pariksha is connected to a text that was part of Mithila's cultural life 600 years ago. This is not nostalgic conservatism but active democratisation: a text that was previously available only to Sanskrit-educated scholars is now available to Maithili-medium school children.

The Purusha Pariksha itself — 107 tales of practical wisdom drawn from pan-Indian didactic traditions including the Panchatantra and the Sanskrit Kathakosa — is a text already in dialogue with popular narrative tradition. Preeti Thakur's children's adaptation is thus not a simplification but a restoration: returning the Purusha Pariksha to something like its original social function as accessible moral narrative.

# PART VI: SYNTHESIS AND CRITICAL ASSESSMENT

## 6.1 Preeti Thakur in the Parallel History Framework

The Videha Parallel History Framework's fundamental argument is that the mainstream Maithili literary canon represents an “onslaught on dignity” (Gajendra Thakur's phrase) — a systematic exclusion of democratic, folk, Dalit, feminist, and Nepal-side traditions. Within this framework, Preeti Thakur's work is exemplary precisely because it is not simply non-canonical but anti-canonical: it insists that children's literature, folk heroes, subaltern communities, and women's cultural labour are not peripheral to Maithili literary culture but central to it.

The critical volumes Preeti Karan Setu Banhal (2024) and Setusham: Vibrant Maithili represent a collective critical act: the Maithili literary community — critics, scholars, poets, students — assembling to declare that Preeti Thakur's contribution constitutes a genuine landmark. This collective critical recognition, produced outside the Sahitya Akademi apparatus, is itself an instance of the parallel literary institution that Videha has been building since 2000.

## 6.2 The Problem of Institutional Invisibility

The most significant critical problem raised by Preeti Thakur's work is not aesthetic but institutional: how does a writer of evident achievement and historical significance remain invisible to the official literary apparatus? The RTI data documented by Vinit Utpal and Ashish Anchinhar (2011–14) showed that over 90% of Sahitya Akademi assignments went to friends and relatives of the 10-member Maithili advisory board. Zero assignments went to authors of the parallel tradition.

Preeti Thakur has not received Sahitya Akademi recognition for the creation of an entirely new genre in Maithili literature. The Bal Sahitya Puraskar of the Sahitya Akademi, which was instituted precisely for children's literature, has not been awarded to the creator of the Maithili children's picture-story book. This institutional silence is not accidental: it is the systematic operation of the same caste-based cultural gatekeeping that the Videha Parallel History has been documenting since 2019.

## 6.3 Formal Achievement: The Chitrakatha as Literary Form

Considered purely on its formal merits, independent of the institutional politics, Preeti Thakur's chitrakatha represents a significant formal achievement. She solves the problem of adapting a richly oral culture's folk narratives to a visual-verbal medium without reducing them to illustration or caption. The complementary dynamics she establishes between image and text (in Nikolajeva's typology) is sophisticated: neither element dominates, each adds what the other cannot provide.

Her illustration style, self-taught rather than academically trained, develops an iconographic vocabulary adequate to the folk heroes she depicts. The characters are recognisably of Mithila — in their clothing, setting, and gesture — without being nostalgic or frozen. The mild criticism in Raman Jha's review (“the picture of the lion looked like a cat”) is a technical observation that does not undermine the overall achievement.

## 6.4 Conclusion: The Civilisational Significance of Preeti Thakur's Work

Preeti Thakur's literary contribution cannot be assessed on a purely aesthetic scale without acknowledging its civilisational dimension. She has: (1) created a new literary genre in Maithili; (2) preserved from oral oblivion dozens of folk-hero narratives and the communities whose identity they anchor; (3) provided Maithili-medium children with a literary culture previously unavailable to them; (4) contributed to the largest archival operation in Mithila's recorded history (the Panji digitisation); (5) adapted a 14th-century classical text for a modern child audience, demonstrating that medieval and modern Maithili constitute a continuous civilisational stream.

These achievements, taken together, constitute not simply a literary career but a programme of cultural survival for a language and culture under multiple pressures: the dominance of Hindi and English, the institutional gatekeeping of the Sahitya Akademi, the gradual erosion of the oral tradition that carries folk memory, and the absence of children's literature in the mother tongue that undermines Maithili's intergenerational transmission.

Assessed through the Indian critical tradition (rasa, dhvani, vakrokti), Western theory (feminist criticism, postcolonial theory, reader-response, Bakhtinian dialogics), the theories of children's literature (Piaget, Vygotsky, Nikolajeva, McGillis), and Navya Nyāya epistemology (vyapti, sabda pramana, the epistemological politics of the Panji), Preeti Thakur emerges as a figure of the

first importance in contemporary Maithili literature, whose recognition by the institutional apparatus is long overdue.

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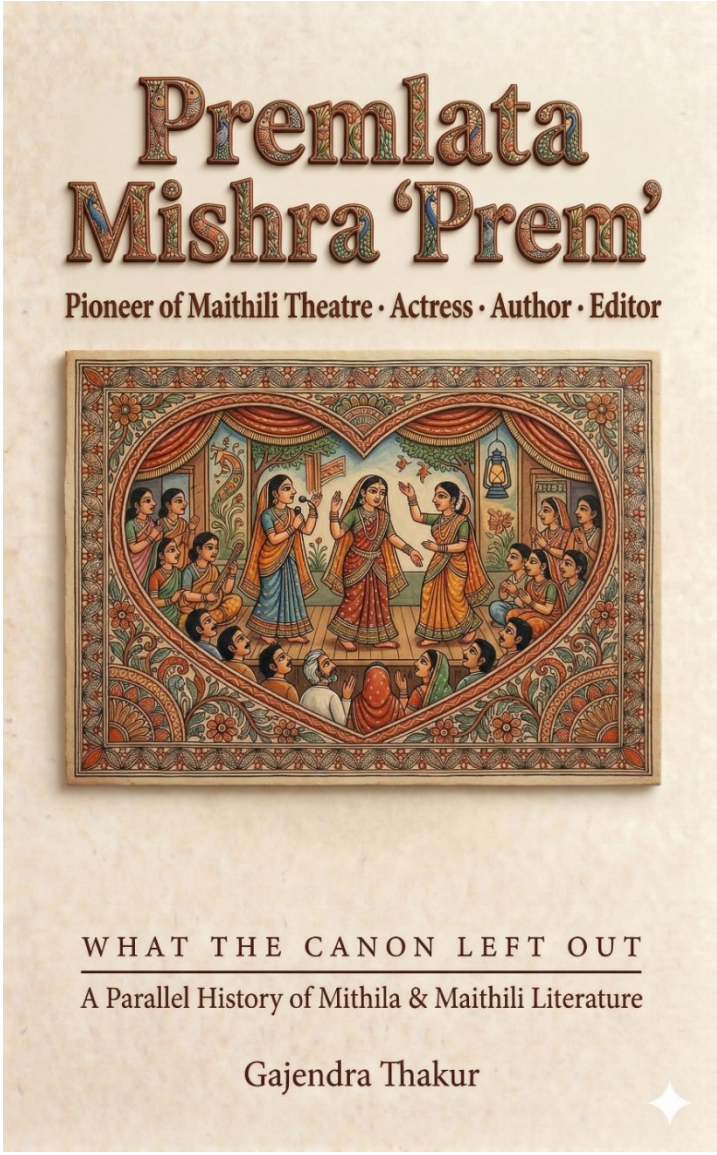


**Premlata Mishra 'Prem'**

*Pioneer of Maithili Theatre · Actress · Author · Editor*

## 1. Biographical Overview

Dr. (Smt.) Premlata Mishra 'Prem' (born 29 September 1948, Rahika, Madhubani, Bihar) is the pre-eminent pioneer of modern Maithili theatre, a

prolific stage and screen actress, short-story writer, memoirist, research scholar, and editor. Her career in performance, literature, and cultural institution-building spans over six decades, making her one of the most consequential figures in the cultural history of the Mithila region in the post-Independence era.

She is the first and most transformative powerful female stage artist of Maithili theatre, credited with normalising and championing women's presence on the Maithili stage at a time when even female roles were performed by men. She has appeared in over 250 Maithili stage productions as well as radio dramas, television serials, and films in Maithili, Hindi, and Bhojpuri. Among her most celebrated film appearances is her role in Mithila Makhaan (directed by Nitin Chandra), which won the Best Maithili Film award at the 63rd National Film Awards (2016) — the first Maithili film from Bihar and Jharkhand to receive a National Award. She also appeared in Prakash Jha's National Award-winning film Damul (1985), one of the most acclaimed Indian political films of its era.

In 2022, she was conferred the Sangeet Natak Akademi Award — India's highest national recognition in the performing arts — for her contribution to Indian theatre as an actor. Videha (ISSN 2229-547X), the first Maithili fortnightly e-journal, dedicated its entire Issue 357 (November 2022) to her as part of the 'Jibait Muda Upekshit' (Living but Neglected) series.

## 1.1 Personal Details

| | |
|---|---|
| **Full Name** | Dr. (Smt.) Premlata Mishra 'Prem' |
| **Born** | 29 September 1948 |
| **Birthplace** | Rahika, Madhubani District, Bihar |
| **Marital Home** | Sirasi, Sitamarhi District, Bihar |
| **Mother** | Late Vrinda Devi |
| **Father** | Pt. Dinanath Jha (Vaidyaji — renowned local physician) |

| | |
|---|---|
| **Husband** | Late Maheshwar Mishra (schoolteacher in Rahika; d. 2018) |
| **Sons (3)** | Manmohan Mishra — Intelligence Bureau; Ravi Ranjan Mishra — Vice President, ILFS Finance; Satyajit Mishra |
| **Daughter** | Anupama — MA Music, singer |
| **Daughters-in-law** | Prabha Mishra, Neelima Mishra, Nutan Mishra |
| **Grandchildren** | Mahendra, Manas, Mukund (grandsons); Meghna, Piyushi (granddaughters) |
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## 1.2 Education

Premlata Mishra passed her Matriculation examination with First Division in 1963 from Rahika High School, Madhubani. She came to Patna in 1964. Subsequently she earned a Postgraduate degree in Maithili, a B.Ed., and a Ph.D. (Doctor of Philosophy). Her doctoral research was on the work of playwright and editor Sudhanshu Shekhar Chaudhary, later published as the monograph Shekhar Prasang.

## 1.3 Professional Career

She served as a Lecturer in Maithili at Bankipur Rajkiya Balika Dwadashiya Vidyalaya (Government Girls' Higher Secondary School), Golhar, Patna, from which she retired in September 2008. Her teaching career was conducted in parallel with her theatre and literary career across four decades.

According to a biographical note published by Manoj Jha in the Videha special issue, her late husband Maheshwar Mishra was also a schoolteacher in Rahika and was deeply supportive of the arts — attending literary gatherings and cultural events, purchasing journals, and encouraging their children in music and performance. Their son Satyajit Mishra studied tabla at the graduate level; two sons sang; their daughter is a performing singer in sugam and folk music.

## 2. Theatre Career

Premlata Mishra's contribution to Maithili theatre is foundational and transformative. She appeared in over 250 plays across radio theatre, stage theatre, television serials, and films over a career that began in the early 1960s. More than the sheer volume, it was her role in normalising and championing women's presence on the Maithili stage that secured her permanent legacy.

In her own words (from the interview conducted by Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil' published in this issue): her teachers at Rahika High School — particularly Headmaster Chandrika Prasadji, himself an artist — encouraged all students to participate in cultural programmes on Republic Day, Independence Day, and Saraswati Puja. Though she was prepared for a play there, social opposition in the village prevented her from performing. However, that preparation proved invaluable when she reached Patna, where it enabled her to enter radio drama and stage theatre with ease.

She came to All India Radio (Patna) in 1964 through the legendary Maithili poet Nagarjun (her 'Yatri Kaka'), who introduced her to Hindi producer Madhukar Gangadhar. She began performing in both the Maithili programme 'Bharati' and the Hindi programme 'Chaupaal', appearing in two plays per month. Chekhov-style naturalistic acting, modern lighting technique (used by director Kunal), and an ensemble of educated Patna artists formed the milieu of her early career.

Premlata Mishra's contribution to Maithili theatre is both foundational and epoch-making. She was described by Shubhnarayan Jha in the Videha special

issue as 'मैथिली रंग मंच के पितामही' (grandmother of Maithili stage) — a title capturing both her seniority and her generative role in the tradition.

## 2.1 Early Years and Path to the Stage

Premlata Mishra grew up in Rahika, a village historically known as a centre of drama, in Madhubani district. Her headmaster at Rahika High School, Chandrika Prasad (himself a theatre-maker), actively encouraged students to perform on Republic Day, Independence Day, and Saraswati Puja. She was prepared for a play written by Govind Babu, 'Basat' (The Wind), but social opposition in the village prevented her from performing. This preparation, however, laid the foundation for everything that followed.

In 1964 she came to Patna, and the poet Nagarjun ('Yatri Kaka' — a paternal relation) took her to All India Radio Patna, introducing her to Hindi producer Madhukar Gangadhar. She quickly joined the AIR drama unit. Biographies in the Videha issue confirm that she was married young — at age 12 per traditional custom — and came to Patna after marriage, with her husband's encouragement. The city provided the institutional and social infrastructure her village had denied her.

A milestone moment in the structural history of Maithili theatre arrived in 1972: from that year onwards, the Chetna Samiti (Patna's foremost Maithili theatre institution, founded by Nagarjun in 1954) began casting women in female roles. Premlata Mishra was at the vanguard of this change. She made her stage debut in the play Dhuwait Lok at Chetna Samiti. Her presence on stage at a time when it was socially exceptional was itself an act of cultural politics.

## 2.2 Radio Theatre

Her radio theatre work was prolific across All India Radio's Maithili programmes 'Bharati' and Hindi programme 'Chaupaal', performing two plays per month. She performed in plays by Sudhanshu Shekhar Chaudhary, Gauri Kant Chaudhary 'Kant', Bhagya Narayan Jha, and others, as well as the landmark Maithili serial Sinhasana Battisi (by Rabindranath Thakur) and several other serials.

| Author | Plays |
|---|---|
| Sudhanshu Shekhar Chaudhary | Aankh ka Parda, Jay Somnath, Chakri, Bahattar, Parivar, Sukh-Sihanta, Kahaan Jaiti Vagare-Vagare, Sonak Tukdi, Padal Kaaj; also: Uthan-Khatola, Ufaanti, Nai Aankh (20-Point Programme) |
| Gauri Kant Chaudhary 'Kant' | Maharshi Vishwamitra |
| Bhagya Narayan Jha | Sonak Mamata, Pahili Tarikh |
| Rabindranath Thakur (serial) | Sinhasana Battisi (Maithili radio serial) |

## 2.3 Stage Theatre

Her stage performances at Chetna Samiti, Arpan, and Bhangima (all Patna) covered works by Maithili's most prominent dramatists. The following is a consolidated list of documented stage productions:

***Plays by Sudhanshu Shekhar Chaudhary***

- Lagak Duri
- Pahil Saanjh
- Bhafait Chahak Jingni
- Letait Aanchal

***Plays by Prof. Harimohan Jha***

- Graduate Putoh
- Bikat Pahan

***Plays by Govind Jha***

- Lodhanath
- Antim Pranam

- Patak Manukh
- Rukmini-Haran (performed 17 times)

***Other Playwrights***

- Lal Paag (Rajkamal)
- Dhuwait Lok (Digambar Jha) — her debut stage play
- Ek Kamal Noreme, Kath ke Lok (Mahendra Malangia)
- Prayashchit / Sunu Janaki (Vatraanand Singh Jha 'Bachuk Bhai')
- Phagun, Chano Dai (Usha Kiran Khan)
- Anhar Jangal, Aagi Dhadhaki Rahal Achi (Dr. Arvind Akku)
- Esagar-Esagar (Late Jyotsna Chandram)
- Plays by Vibhuti Anand and Kumar Shailendra

## 2.4 Television Work

She appeared in multiple Doordarshan Bihar serials in Hindi: Parva Bhara Mithila, Veer Kunwar Singh, Viplav, and Ek Kahani, among others. In Bhojpuri she featured in the serial Sanchi Piritiya.

## 2.5 Film Career

Her film work spans Maithili, Hindi, and Bhojpuri cinema across a period of approximately four decades:

***Maithili Films***

- Mamta Gabay Geet — her first film
- Sasta Jingni Mahag Sinur (released 1999; successful at the Maithili box office; songs by Md. Aziz, Sadhana Sargam, Udit Narayan, Deepa Narayan)
- Lal Paag
- Mithila Makhaan — directed by Nitin Chandra; won Best Maithili Film at the 63rd National Film Awards (2016)
- Babeetiya

Mithila Makhaan was a landmark production in Maithili cinema history. Produced by Neetu Chandra (Champaran Talkies) and directed by her brother

Nitin Chandra, it was shot across the USA, Canada, India, and Nepal — the first Maithili film shot on that scale and budget. The National Award jury was headed by filmmaker Ramesh Sippy. It is the first Maithili film from Bihar and Jharkhand ever to receive a National Award. Playback singers included Udit Narayan, Hariharan, Suresh Wadkar, and Sonu Nigam. Premlata Mishra played a central maternal role. Munni Kamat writes in the Videha special issue that her performance in this film is etched permanently in the viewer's consciousness.

***Hindi Films***

- Damul (1985) — directed and produced by Prakash Jha. A landmark Hindi-language film on bonded labour in rural Bihar; won the National Film Award for Best Feature Film (1984) and the Filmfare Critics Award. The film was also invited to competition sections at the Montreal, Chicago, and Moscow film festivals. It remains one of the most respected Indian social-realist films.
- Katha Madhopur Ki — tele-film on Panchayati Raj
- Maryada, Jahaan Chah Wahan Raah, Dehati Duniya, Ragini — tele-films

***Bhojpuri Films***

- Dulha Ganga Paar Ke
- Babuaa Hamar

## 2.6 Institutions and the Architecture of Maithili Theatre

In her interview in Videha Issue 357, Premlata Mishra provided a detailed institutional history of modern Maithili theatre, of which she is a living repository:

- **Chetna Samiti, Patna:** Founded by poet Nagarjun ('Yatri') in 1954; the oldest and most foundational Maithili literary and cultural organization. She made her stage debut here. From 1972, women began performing female roles in Chetna Samiti productions — a historic shift in which she was central.
- **Arpan, Patna:** Under Mantreshwar Jha's leadership, Arpan greatly expanded Maithili theatre's reach, organising international Natya Saptah (Drama

Week) festivals with participating groups from Kolkata, Delhi, Virajnagar (Nepal), Janakpur, Jamshedpur, and Begusarai.

- **Bhangima, Patna:** Established on 4 August 1984 by committed theatre workers committed to Mithilanchal's cultural heritage; registered under the Societies Registration Act (Registration No. 655/1986). She served as editor of its irregular theatre journal and as a performer.
- **Mailorang (Prakash Jha):** Active contemporary Maithili theatre group; Delhi-based.
- **Mithilaangan (Mahendra Malangia) and Barahmaasa:** Contemporary active groups she described in her interview as sustaining the tradition.

## 3. Literary Works

### 3.1 Published Books

| Title | Year | Genre |
|---|---|---|
| *Ego Valik Sineh (एगो वलीह सिनेह)* | 2005 | Short Story Collection (Maithili) |
| *O Din O Pal (ओ दिन ओ पल)* | 2005 | Memoir / Reminiscence Collection (Maithili) |
| *Shekhar Prasang (शेखर प्रसंग)* | — | Research Monograph / Doctoral Work (Maithili) |

### 3.2 Critical Notes on Her Books

Gajendra Thakur's extensive critical essay in the special issue ('Premlata Mishra Prem'k Bahanne') offers the most detailed published evaluation of her three books:

***Shekhar Prasang (*शेखर प्रसंग*)***

This research monograph, based on her doctoral work, studies the playwright, director, and editor Sudhanshu Shekhar Chaudhary — the most significant

figure in Maithili radio theatre and one of its leading stage directors. The study has four chapters: personality and body of work (Ch. 1), textual literary criticism (Ch. 2), Hindi writings (Ch. 3), and conclusions (Ch. 4). Among notable observations in the monograph is the account of how Chaudhary wrote — composing entire plays mentally and setting them down in a single draft, without revision, a creative discipline compared by Gajendra Thakur in the Videha issue reminiscent of George Bernard Shaw's shorthand-and-dictation method. The monograph also documents the role of the Mithila Mihir journal in building a generation of Maithili writers.

### *O Din O Pal (*ओ दिन ओ पल*)*

This memoir collection of 12 pieces is the book most extensively commented upon in the Videha special issue — by Hitanath Jha, Abha Jha, and Gajendra Thakur. It came close to being an autobiography before resolving into a looser memoir form. Its most discussed piece is the memoir 'Hamar Kakka: Yatriji' (My Uncle: Nagarjun), which documents their relationship and Nagarjun's progressive domestic practice: he divided household cooking duties equitably, giving Premlata and his daughter-in-law a full day off per week (with his eldest daughter-in-law Shobha cooking on that day) — an act she records as her first conscious experience of rights. The memoir is also notable for its accounts of cultural Patna in the 1960s and 1970s. Other memoirs include accounts of her relationship with theatre luminaries including Sudhanshu Shekhar Chaudhary, and vivid portraits of early Maithili radio theatre life. Vibha Rani's essay in the special issue provides an extended literary-critical reading of this book. Abha Jha's essay in the issue is dedicated to this book's literary analysis, treating it as a landmark in Maithili women's life-writing.

## The Memoir 'O Din O Pal': A Literary Landmark

Several contributors to the special issue comment specifically on her memoir collection. Abhaa Jha's essay is titled 'Rangkarmi Premlata Mishr'k Sahityik Vahi — O Din O Pal' (The Literary Register of Theatre Artist Premlata Mishra — O Din O Pal), and provides an extended reading of the book as a landmark in Maithili women's life-writing. Hitanath Jha's essay is also named after the same book.

The memoir is valued not just for its personal content but for its sociological documentation: it records the social life of Patna's Maithili-speaking intelligentsia in the 1960s and 1970s, the emergence of women in the public cultural sphere, and the internal dynamics of theatre and radio institutions at a formative period.

***Ego Valik Sineh* (एगो वलीह सिनेह)**

Her short-story collection in Maithili. Gajendra Thakur notes in the special issue that several stories surprised him with their quality and range, establishing her not merely as a theatre practitioner who also writes, but as a genuine literary voice in the short-story form.

### 3.3 Editorial Work

- Sandhya Goshti (सांध्य गोष्ठी) — irregular periodical, which she began editing from 2008 after retirement; her primary ongoing editorial project.
- Bhangima (भंगिमा) — the theatre-focused irregular journal of the Bhangima group; she served as its editor for a period.
- Janaki (जानकी) — the souvenir of the Maithili Mahila Sangh (Maithili Women's Association), Patna.

## 4. National Recognition: Sangeet Natak Akademi Award 2022

The most significant of all the national honours accorded to Premlata Mishra is the Sangeet Natak Akademi Award for 2022, India's highest national recognition in the performing arts, conferred by India's National Academy of Music, Dance and Drama under the Ministry of Culture, Government of India. The award carries a cash prize of ₹1,00,000 along with a Tamrapatra (copper plaque) and an Angavastram (traditional stole). The Akademi Awards have been conferred since 1952 and are among the most prestigious honours in the Indian performing arts.

The official PIB citation for the award describes her as follows:

*"Born on 29 September 1948 in Bihar, Premlata Mishra is considered a pioneer of Maithili theatre. Her journey began in the 1960s, promoting Maithili dramas through Akashvani (All India Radio) before transitioning these to the stage. Known for her over 250 lead roles in Maithili dramas, she has also acted in films and television serials. Her impact extends beyond the stage as she played a crucial role in shifting societal views towards [women in theatre]. Through her dedication to promoting Maithili language and culture through theatre, Mishra has garnered widespread recognition. As a doyenne of Maithili theatre, she has not only enriched the artistic landscape but... Shrimati Premlata Mishra receives the Sangeet Natak Akademi Award for the year 2022 for her contribution to Indian theatre as an actor."*

The award was conferred by the President of India at a ceremony held at Vigyan Bhawan, New Delhi. It was the culmination of a body of work spanning over six decades in Maithili theatre and film.

## 5. Institutional Affiliations

She has served as President, Vice-President, Secretary, and Treasurer at various points in the following organisations:

- Chetna Samiti, Patna — Maithili's oldest and most prestigious literary and cultural institution
- Bhangima, Patna — Maithili theatre group; active since 4 August 1984
- Arpan, Patna — cultural organisation instrumental in spreading Maithili theatre
- Maithili Mahila Sangh (Maithili Women's Association), Patna
- Vandana Rani Kendra, Patna
- Bihar Sangeet Natak Akademi, Patna — Member, Executive Committee
- Maithili Akademi, Patna — Member, Cultural and Folk Stage Committee

She has also broadcast numerous stories, talks, and discussions on All India Radio and Doordarshan (the national broadcaster).

## 6. Awards and Honours — Complete Record

The following comprehensive table records all documented awards. National-level awards are highlighted; entries include source notes where independently verified.

| Year | Award / Honour | Awarding Body / Source |
|---|---|---|
| **1985** | Special Contribution to Maithili Theatre *(Videha 357)* | *Chetna Samiti, Patna* |
| **1987** | Honour for Maithili Theatre contribution *(Videha 357)* | *Mithila Vikas Parishad, Kolkata* |
| **1988** | Shailabala Puraskar *(Videha 357)* | *Chetna Samiti, Patna* |
| **1988** | Joint Honour *(Videha 357)* | *Akhil Bharatiya Mithila Sangh, Delhi & Arpan, Patna* |
| **1992** | Anil Kumar Mukherjee Pratham Shikhar Samman *(Videha 357)* | *Bihar Art Theatre, Patna* |
| **1992** | Kalashri Title *(Videha 357)* | *Bihar Pradesh BNS, Patna* |
| **1992** | Best Character Actress Award (7th Natya Competition) *(Videha 357)* | *Bhanu Kala Kendra, Virajnagar (Nepal) & Arpan, Patna* |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **1996** | Pataliputra Award (theatre contribution) *(Videha 357)* | *Hindi Rangmanch Prangan, at 12th Pataliputra Mahotsav* |
| **2000** | Mithila Vibhuti Samman *(Videha 357)* | *Vidyapati Seva Sansthan, Darbhanga* |
| **2000** | Mithila Vibhuti Samman *(Videha 357)* | *Prayag Sanskritik Sangam, Allahabad* |
| **2004** | Honour: Social Service through Theatre *(Videha 357)* | *Rotary Patna Midtown, Patna* |
| **2007** | Honour at International Maithili Conference *(Videha 357)* | *International Maithili Conference, Delhi* |
| **2007** | Kalakaksha Samman *(Videha 357)* | *Kala Kaksha, Patna* |
| **2009** | Noor Fatima Award *(Videha 357)* | *Hindi Naatya Manch 'Prayas', Patna* |
| **2011** | First Jyotirishwar Rangshirsh Samman *(Videha 357)* | *Maillorang Theatre Group, Delhi* |
| **2011** | Honour at 4th International Maithili Conference *(Videha 357)* | *Mithila Sanskritik Samanvay Samiti, Guwahati* |
| **2012** | Mahendra Jha Samman *(Videha 357)* | *Maithil Samaj, Rahika* |
| **2012** | Mithila Vibhuti Samman *(Videha 357)* | *Akhil Bharatiya Mithila Sangh, Delhi* |
| **2013** | Bhikhari Thakur (Rangmanch) Varishtha | *— [Senior Theatre Award]* |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | Puraskar *(Videha 357)* | |
| **2016** | Contribution to Film Development Award *(Videha 357)* | *Bihar Rajya Film Vikas aur Vitta Nigam, Patna* |
| **2018** | Bhamati Stri Samman *(Videha 357)* | *Sanskritik Samiti, Andhrathadi* |
| **2021** | Lifetime Achievement Award *(Videha 357)* | *Shivam Productions Pvt. Ltd.* |
| **2022** | Navraj Samman *(Videha 357)* | — |
| **2022** | Honour: Outstanding Participation *(Videha 357)* | *Maithili Sahitya Kala, Rangmanch Mahotsav* |
| **2022** | Sangeet Natak Akademi Award — for contribution to Indian Theatre (Actor) *(Sangeet Natak Akademi (National))* | *Sangeet Natak Akademi, Govt. of India — highest national performing arts award* |

## 7. Critical and Scholarly Assessment

### 7.1 As Pioneer of Maithili Women's Theatre

The most transformative aspect of Premlata Mishra's contribution was structural rather than merely performative: she broke, through personal example and active mentorship, the convention that kept Mithila's educated women off the public stage. Manoj Jha writes in the Videha special issue that in the era when she entered theatre, women going on stage were viewed negatively by society; she faced direct opposition in her own village on

multiple occasions. Yet she persisted, and by doing so changed the terms of what was possible. 'She was perhaps born on this earth to transform society's thinking,' Jha observes.

Her entry into Chetna Samiti in the early 1970s, coinciding with the institution's decision from 1972 to cast women in female roles, was a turning point not just for her but for Maithili cultural life. Munni Kamat writes: 'She encouraged more and more women to get involved in stage productions. Before her, society would continue to watch men in female roles. Premlata Mishra Prem was perhaps born to change society's thinking.' Shubhnarayan Jha's title for her — 'मैथिली रंग मंच के पितामही' (Grandmother of Maithili Stage) — has become the recognised honorific.

## 7.2 Gajendra Thakur's Extended Critical Essay

Gajendra Thakur's essay 'Premlata Mishra Prem'k Bahanne' (Videha 357, pp. 85–98) is the most substantial and analytically ambitious piece in the special issue, combining literary criticism of her three books with a wider critique of the institutional politics of Maithili cultural life. A key passage concerns the Sahitya Akademi Yuva Puraskar 2022, for which Premlata Mishra served as one of three jurors (alongside Keskar Thakur and Rajan Kumar Singh). Thakur documents that the jury voted, not on literary merit, but along caste lines, resulting in the rejection of Munni Kamat's poetry collection Antatah — which Thakur regards as clearly the superior work — in favour of a candidate whose primary qualification was caste affiliation and institutional connectivity.

Thakur's analysis of Premlata Mishra's vote is nuanced and ethically rigorous: he does not simply condemn her, but anatomises the structural pressure on a woman artist within a system dominated by caste networks, noting that 'all must pay a price' — in her case, the price of her vote as a juror. He observes that she surrendered both her identity as a woman and her identity as an artist in that moment, becoming instead an instrument of caste consensus. This is not a minor observation in an issue otherwise devoted to celebrating her achievements; it is a marker of Videha's editorial commitment to honest assessment over hagiography.

### 7.3 The Memoir as Feminist Document

Vibha Rani's essay — titled 'Rangmanch mein Raja Kiyo Nahin Hoit Hai' (There Are No Kings on Stage) — provides a feminist reading of Premlata Mishra's life and theatre work. The title points toward the democratic and non-hierarchical ethos of theatre as a practice, which Vibha Rani reads as a key feature of Premlata Mishra's practice: on stage, social rank collapses, and the actor's skill is the only currency. Abha Jha's essay treats O Din O Pal as a landmark in Maithili women's life-writing, a document of the cultural Patna of the 1960s and 1970s as experienced by a woman artist navigating between social convention and creative ambition.

### 7.4 Maithili Theatre in Cultural-Historical Context

Understanding Premlata Mishra's significance requires understanding the specific cultural-historical moment of post-Independence Maithili theatre in Patna. Chetna Samiti, founded by Nagarjun in 1954, was the nucleus of Maithili literary and cultural life, producing writers, editors, and theatre practitioners. The radio programme 'Bharati' on AIR Patna was one of the principal public spheres for Maithili performance. The city of Patna was home to a Maithili-speaking educated community of government servants, academics, and professionals — the audience and participants of this cultural world.

Within this milieu, the presence of women on stage was socially contested well into the 1960s. The Wikipedia article on Maithili literature notes that as late as 1958, when Harimohan Jha's wife Subhadra Jha entered Chetna Samiti as a stage performer, it was considered 'not less than a phenomenon for Maithil ladies.' Premlata Mishra came onto this stage in the early 1970s, and through her decades of work became the figure who made it normal. Her memoir O Din O Pal is one of the principal archives of this transformation.

## 8. Key Films in Context

### 8.1 Mithila Makhaan (2016, National Award)

Mithila Makhaan, directed by Nitin Chandra and produced by Neetu Chandra (Champaran Talkies), is the only Maithili film in over 50 years of Maithili

filmmaking to have won a National Film Award. It received the Best Maithili Film award at the 63rd National Film Awards (2016), with the jury headed by Ramesh Sippy. The film was shot in USA, Canada, India, and Nepal; it depicts the emotional and political landscape of Bihar's Mithila region through the return of a Bihari engineer from Toronto to his ancestral village. Premlata Mishra played a central maternal role in the film.

Despite the National Award, the film struggled to find theatrical or OTT distribution, eventually being released on the makers' own platform bejod.in after Bollywood stars including Hrithik Roshan, Nawazuddin Siddiqui, Manoj Bajpayee, Vidya Balan, and Jackie Shroff promoted it publicly. Hrithik Roshan called it 'the first ever Maithili film from Bihar to win the National Award.' The film has since been widely recognised as a landmark in the history of Maithili cinema.

### 8.2 Damul (1985, National Award — Best Feature Film)

Damul (meaning 'Bonded Until Death') was written and directed by Prakash Jha. It is based on the story Kaalsootra by Shaiwal, set in rural Bihar in 1984, and focuses on the feudal system of bonded labour (panha), caste oppression, and rural migration. The film starred Annu Kapoor, Sreela Majumdar, Manohar Singh, and Deepti Naval in lead roles. It won the National Film Award for Best Feature Film (1984) and the Filmfare Critics Award for Best Movie (1985). It was invited to competition sections at the Montreal, Chicago, and Moscow international film festivals.

Premlata Mishra appeared in a supporting role in Damul. The film is one of the most critically acclaimed works of Indian social-realist cinema, and her association with it marks one of the significant moments in her crossover from Maithili stage and radio to nationally distributed Hindi cinema.

## 9. The Videha Special Issue (No. 357, 2022)

Videha's Issue 357 (01 November 2022) is the journal's seventh 'Jibait Muda Upekshit' (Living but Neglected) special issue, and its first dedicated to a

woman. Announced in August 2022, it was assembled by Gajendra Thakur and presents 22 contributions focused exclusively on Premlata Mishra. The editorial note observes that this is not an abhinandan granth (a commemorative felicitation volume) — Videha's special issues deliberately make room for critical and even adversarial assessments alongside appreciative ones. It is the most comprehensive scholarly resource on her life and work assembled to date.

| | Title / Topic | Contributor |
|---|---|---|
| 2.1 | Editorial note on the special issue context | *Gajendra Thakur / Videha* |
| 2.2 | Biographical profile of Dr. Premlata Mishra 'Prem' | *Presented by Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil'* |
| 2.3 | Poem: Premlata Mishra 'Prem' | *Kunal* |
| 2.4 | Hamar Bachchi Mausi (My Aunt) | *Kanupriya* |
| 2.5 | Maithili'k Sashakt Rangkarmi Premlata Mishra Prem | *Munni Kamat* |
| 2.6 | Hamra Lel Premlata Di | *Jaya Jha* |
| 2.7 | Hamar Bachchi (Premlata) | *Usha Kiran Khan* |
| 2.8 | O Din O Pal: Premlata Mishra 'Prem' | *Hitanath Jha* |
| 2.9 | Maithili Rang Manch ke Pitamahi Premlata Mishra 'Prem' | *Shubhnarayan Jha* |
| 2.10 | 'Rangmanch mein Raja Kiyo Nahin Hoit Hai' | *Vibha Rani* |
| 2.11 | Mithila'k Vidushi Parampara'k Anupam | *Dr. Shiv Kumar Mishra* |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | Stambha | |
| 2.12 | Kala lel Varishtha Nai, Dakshata Mapdand Hai | *Ashish Anchinhar* |
| 2.13 | Rangkarmi Premlata Mishr'k Sahityik Vahi — O Din O Pal | *Abha Jha* |
| 2.14 | Nari Sashaktikaran ke Agradoot, Pahil Sashakt Mahila... | *Manoj Jha* |
| 2.15 | Dr. Premlata Mishra 'Prem': Mithila'k Vilakshan Vidushi... | *Prem Kant Chaudhary* |
| 2.16 | Mithilaputri (Poem) | *Kamlendra Jha 'Kamal'* |
| 2.17 | Premlata Bahin | *Lakshman Jha Sagar* |
| 2.18 | Premlata Mishra 'Prem'k Bahanne (Critical Essay) | *Gajendra Thakur* |
| 2.19 | Maithili Rangmanch'k Preranashrot: Premlata Mishra Prem | *Ajit Kumar Jha* |
| 2.20 | Interview with Premlata Mishra 'Prem' | *Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil' (interviewer)* |
| 2.21 | Premlata Prasang | *Uday Chandra Jha 'Vinod'* |
| 2.22 | Maithil Nari'k Sanskritik-Sahityik Svar — Premlata Mishra Prem | *Pradeep Pushpa* |

## 10. Historical Significance

Premlata Mishra's life and career sit at the intersection of several of the major cultural forces of post-Independence Mithila. She represents:

- **The democratisation of Maithili cultural space:** Her generation were the first to insist that women belonged on the Maithili stage as performers, not merely as audiences. She created the conditions for all subsequent generations of Maithili women in theatre.
- **The documenter of a vanished cultural world:** Her memoir O Din O Pal is an irreplaceable record of Patna's Maithili-speaking cultural intelligentsia of the 1960s and 1970s — a social world built around AIR Patna, Chetna Samiti, the literary journal culture, and the city's Maithili-medium schools.
- **The embodiment of Nagarjun's cultural legacy:** Her relationship with Nagarjun ('Yatri Kaka') was foundational — he brought her to AIR, shaped her early cultural formation, and modelled in his domestic practice the progressive attitudes toward women that she later wrote about. She is one of the direct human embodiments of his cultural and social vision.
- **A bridge across media:** Her career — spanning radio drama, stage, Doordarshan, Maithili cinema, Hindi art cinema, and Bhojpuri film — gives her a breadth of cultural reach and visibility that no other Maithili woman artist of her generation can match. Her appearance in Damul (1985) and Mithila Makhaan (National Award, 2016) connected Maithili cultural life to national and international audiences.
- **A contested figure at the intersection of art and institutional politics:** As Gajendra Thakur's essay in Videha makes clear, the history of Maithili cultural institutions is one of caste dominance and institutional gatekeeping. Premlata Mishra's career navigated this landscape, sometimes with independence and sometimes with compromise. The Videha special issue is the most detailed account of both her achievements and the structural pressures that shaped her.

## 11. Bibliography and Sources

### Primary Source: Videha Special Issue

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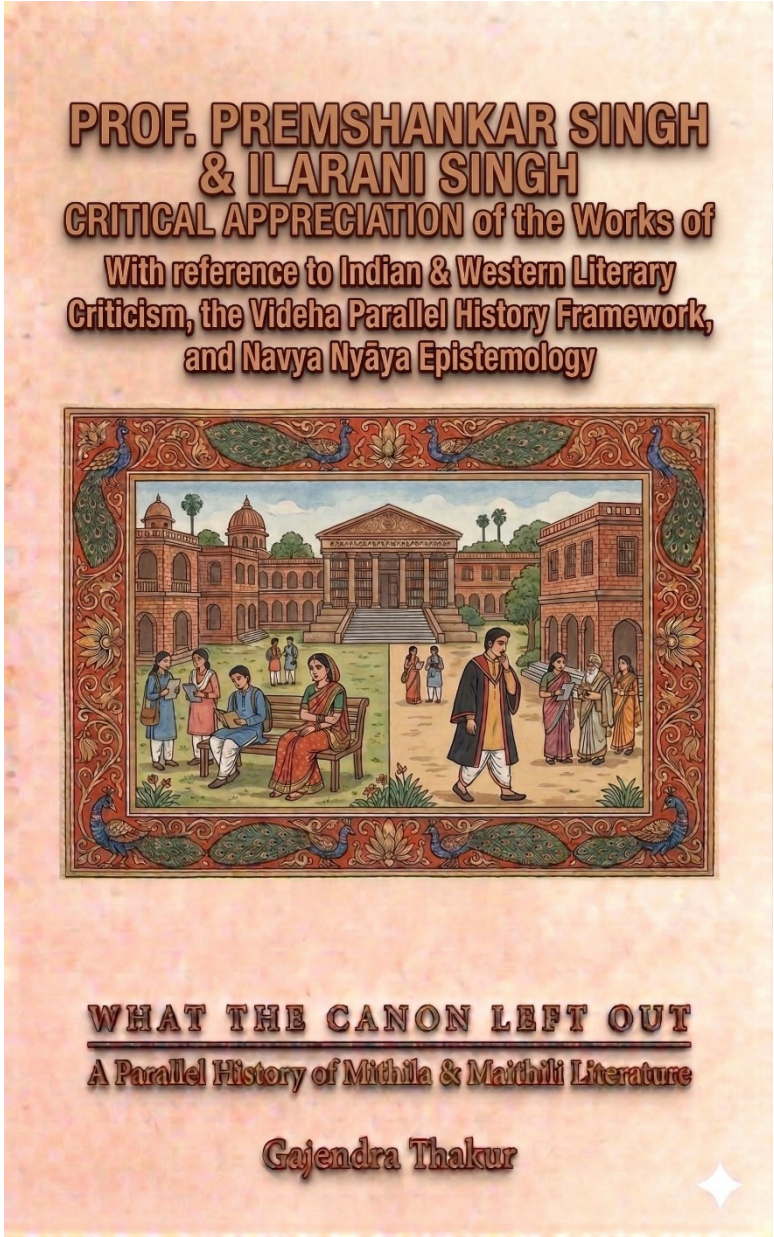
**LESSON 058 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**



# RESEARCH & CRITICAL APPRECIATION

*of the Works of*

**Prof. Premshankar Singh**

&

**Ilarani Singh**

*With reference to Indian & Western Literary Criticism, the Videha Parallel History Framework, and Navya Nyāya Epistemology*

## I. Preamble: Scope and Methodology

This research monograph undertakes a comprehensive critical appreciation of the literary, scholarly, and creative works of Prof. Premshankar Singh and Ilarani Singh — two pivotal figures in contemporary Maithili literature. Their contributions, archived in the Videha Maithili repository (www.videha.co.in), span the genres of literary history, criticism, drama, poetry, textual scholarship, and women's writing in Maithili. The study examines four primary texts: (1) Maithili Bhasha Sahitya: Beesam Shatabdi (Premshankar Singh, Shruti Publication, Delhi, 2009); (2) Vyadhibhakti-tarangini of Vidyapati, edited by Premshankar Singh (Mithila Darpan Prakashan, Mumbai, 2008); (3) Maithili Rangmanch, associated with Ilarani Singh; and (4) Ijoriyak Angaithi-Mor: A Collection of Maithili Poems of Poetesses (ed. Mala Jha & Vibha Jha, Navarambh Prakashan, 2022), in which Ilarani Singh's poetic presence is documented.

The methodology integrates multiple critical frameworks: Indian rasa-dhvani aesthetics (Bharata, Abhinavagupta, Anandavardhana); Western theories of historicism, feminist criticism, formalism, postcolonialism, and new criticism; the Videha Parallel History Framework as articulated by Gajendra Thakur; and Navya Nyāya epistemological techniques as developed by Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya of Mithila (14th century CE) and his successors including Raghunatha Śiromaṇi and Vācaspati Miśra. The application of Navya Nyāya tools — particularly the concepts of pramāṇa (valid sources of knowledge), anumāna (inference), vyāpti (pervasion), and avacchedakatā (delimitation) — to literary criticism provides a unique epistemological lens that is both native to the Mithilā tradition and philosophically rigorous.

# II. Biographical and Institutional Context

## 2.1 Prof. Premshankar Singh

Prof. Premshankar Singh is a retired University Professor and Head, Department of Maithili, Tilka Manjhi Bhagalpur University (formerly Bhagalpur University), Bhagalpur — Bihar 812007. Based in Mumbai (address: 601, ICICI Bank Apartment, Mumbai) after retirement, his scholarly career spans decades of dedicated teaching, research, and publication in Maithili language and literature. As an academic operating from a university located in what might be called the southern transitional zone of Mithila culture — where Maithili meets Angika and Bengali — his work carries a particular awareness of linguistic boundaries and cultural overlaps.

He is recognized as one of the foremost critics of Maithili literature of the twentieth century. His preface to Maithili Bhasha Sahitya: Beesam Shatabdi records that the work was first serialized in the Videha e-journal (www.videha.co.in), the pioneering Maithili fortnightly founded by Gajendra Thakur in 2004, before being published in book form by Shruti Publication, Delhi, in 2009 (ISBN: 978-93-80538-12-9). This itself testifies to his close association with the Videha Maithili movement. Gajendra Thakur's note in that volume acknowledges Singh's role as a "truth-seeking critic" who identifies casteism, communalism, and literary blackmail within the Maithili literary ecosystem — a gesture consonant with the Videha Parallel History Framework's commitment to inclusivity and counter-hegemonic literary history.

His editorial work on the Vyadhibhakti-tarangini of Vidyapati — a Sanskrit text patronized by King Narasimha Deva Narayan — represents a major contribution to Maithili-Sanskrit textual scholarship. The preface (dated Shravan Purnima 2008) acknowledges assistance from the Dhaka University Library manuscript, the work of Prof. Ashutosh Bhattacharya (whose 1966 article from Dhaka University forms the editorial basis), and scholars including Prof. Upendranath Mallik and Dr. Vinay Kumar Mahato. The editorial recovery of a palm-leaf manuscript in Tirhuta/Bangla script is a significant act of cultural preservation.

## 2.2 Ilarani Singh

Ilarani Singh is a Maithili woman writer, playwright, and poet whose work is associated with the Videha corpus and the broader tradition of women's writing

in Maithili. Her book Maithili Rangmanch (archived in the Videha repository) is a contribution to Maithili theatre studies. The anthology Ijoriyak Angaithi-Mor: A Collection of Maithili Poems of Poetesses (Navarambh Prakashan, 2022, edited by Mala Jha and Vibha Jha, ISBN listed, Price Rs. 300) situates her within a larger tradition of Maithili women's poetry. The title Ijoriyak Angaithi Mor — meaning something like 'The Fireplace of Light That is Mine' — gestures at the feminine, domestic-sacred space as a site of creative identity, a trope that recurs in women's writing across the Mithila region.

In the Videha Parallel History Framework, Ilarani Singh represents the counter-tradition of women's voices that mainstream literary academies — the Sahitya Akademi, Maithili Akademi, Maithili-Bhojpuri Akademi — have historically marginalized. Her presence in the Videha archive situates her as a participant in what Gajendra Thakur calls the 'parallel stream' of Maithili literature: one that is inclusive of lower-caste, women, and non-elite voices.

## III. The Videha Parallel History Framework

The Videha Parallel History Framework (VPHF) is the theoretical and editorial foundation of the Videha Maithili eJournal (ISSN 2229-547X, www.videha.co.in), inaugurated formally on 1 January 2008 as a fortnightly e-journal by Gajendra Thakur (b. 1971, Bhagalpur). Its roots go back to the blog 'Bhalsarik Gachh' (5 July 2004), the first recorded Maithili presence on the internet.

The VPHF operates on the principle that Maithili literary history, as institutionally narrated by government Academies and mainstream publishing, has consistently suppressed a 'parallel stream' of literature. This parallel stream includes: (i) writers from non-Brahmin, OBC, Dalit, and Adivasi communities; (ii) women writers; (iii) writers who challenge caste hegemony, brahminical gatekeeping, and 'mediocrity' promoted by patronage networks; (iv) writers based in the diaspora or outside the traditional Mithila zone; and (v) scholars engaged in genuine textual recovery rather than careerist criticism.

Gajendra Thakur, who deciphered approximately 11,000 Maithili palm-leaf manuscripts (Panji records, genealogical records of Mithila) and published the landmark 'Genome Mapping 450 AD to 2009 AD – Mithilak Panji Prabandh,' argues that the very panji system — used by Brahmin pandits to control caste endogamy — contains within it records of approximately 100 inter-caste

marriages that the hegemonic narrative suppresses. This is parallel history as manuscript archaeology.

> *"The references to parallel literature are found in the Vedas, where Narashanshi is referred to as parallel literature. The need for parallel literature in Maithili arose due to the constant onslaught on literature and dignity by the Public and Private Academies, for example, Maithili-Bhojpuri Akademi of Delhi, Maithili Akademi of Patna, Sahitya Akademi of Delhi, Nepal's Prajna Pratishthan, all of which are government Academies." — Gajendra Thakur, Videha*

Within the VPHF, both Premshankar Singh and Ilarani Singh occupy distinct but complementary positions. Singh's critical work — with its insistence on identifying 'blackmailing literature' (blackmail sahitya, where critics use reviews as instruments of personal revenge or praise-seeking), its recovery of forgotten or suppressed texts like the Vyadhibhakti-tarangini, and its systematic survey of the twentieth century — functions as a counter-hegemonic literary history. Ilarani Singh's theatre writings and poetry, as a woman writer, represent the parallel stream of gendered authorship.

The VPHF also posits that Maithili's identity is etymologically rooted in the ancient kingdom of Videha (Janakpur, Nepal / Mithila region), predating even the Aryan settlement narratives — a claim that challenges the Sanskrit-centric periodization of Maithili literary history by Western Indologists like G.A. Grierson (1851–1941), who coined the modern use of 'Maithili' in his Bihar Peasant Life and Linguistic Survey of India.

## IV. Analysis of Primary Texts

### 4.1 Maithili Bhasha Sahitya: Beesam Shatabdi (2009) — Premshankar Singh

This volume — whose title translates as 'Maithili Language and Literature: The Twentieth Century' — is a landmark work of Maithili literary criticism and literary history. Published by Shruti Publication, New Delhi (price Rs. 400, ISBN 978-93-80538-12-9), it is written in Maithili using the Devanagari script and contains the following major sections, according to its table of contents: Maithili Bhasha Sahitya; Lokgatha (Folk Ballads); Lok Natya (Folk Theatre); Beesam Shatabdi: Varnayug (Twentieth Century: The Golden Age);

Paramparik Natak (Traditional Drama); Samajik Vivart ke Jivan Jha; Harimohan Jha's influence on later writers; Maithili Movement's Conscious Harbinger (Jayakant Mishra); Smaran Sahitya (Memoir Literature); Amar's Ekankis (One-Act Plays): Social Reality; Mayanand's Radio Craft; and Chetna Samiti and the Theatre Stage.

### *Critical Scope and Method*

The work is, in Gajendra Thakur's characterization, a collection of 'niband-bandh-samalochna' — essays, structured arguments, and criticism — that covers both the beloved and the uncomfortable aspects of Maithili literature over a century. Singh deploys what can be characterized as an evaluative-historicist method: he surveys the genre field (poetry, drama, one-act plays, folk ballad, memoir) within a socio-historical frame, tracking the 'parivartan' (transformation) produced by education, print culture, railways, self-governance, and social consciousness.

His preface declares: 'In the changed milieu, literature has acquired a new pulsation (nava spandan), which is its living testimony.' This emphasis on socio-historical determinism of literary form is consistent with Western historicist criticism (Hippolyte Taine's race-milieu-moment triad, Lukács's Historical Novel, Terry Eagleton's materialist criticism) but is differently inflected by an insider's moral commitment to Maithili cultural survival.

What distinguishes Singh's work is his insistence on identifying what Gajendra Thakur calls 'mediocrity' and 'blackmail literature': Singh explicitly identifies caste bias, sectarian criticism, and mutual praise clubs (writers praising each other's mediocre work at sammelans). In the preface note, Thakur writes: 'Premshankar Singh does not spare any particular caste or community — he identifies them all and marks where inferiority complex-driven literature cannot be welfare-oriented.' This ethical-critical stance is rare in literary history.

### *Contributions to Maithili Literary History*

The text covers folk ballad (Lokgatha), giving special attention to the contribution of Manipuri scholars to the field of Maithili folk ballads — an unusual cross-regional insight. The section on folk drama (Lok Natya) traces the deep roots of Maithili theatrical tradition. Singh's survey of the twentieth century identifies it as a 'Varnayug' (Golden Age) — not without irony, since the same period saw the suppression of Maithili's claim to independent linguistic status.

The sections on Harimohon Jha (a landmark Maithili humorist and playwright), Jayakant Mishra (activist for Maithili language recognition), Mayanand's radio drama, and Chetna Samiti's theatre work provide rare critical documentation of institutions and individuals who shaped Maithili modernity. Singh's treatment of Mayanand Mishra's radio craft is particularly valuable — placing it alongside mainstream narratives of All India Radio's role in Hindi promotion at the expense of regional languages.

The text also serialized in Videha over multiple issues before book publication — itself a signal of Singh's alignment with digital-democratic publishing as against the gatekeeping of print institutions. Thakur notes that this Videha publication first brought Singh's critical voice to a global Maithili readership. The book's publication by Shruti Publication, one of the few Delhi-based Maithili-language publishers, is likewise significant as part of the diaspora-driven revitalization of Maithili print culture.

## 4.2 Vyadhibhakti-tarangini of Vidyapati — Edited by Premshankar Singh (2008)

This editorial work represents a different order of scholarly achievement. The Vyadhibhakti-tarangini (literally 'Waves of Devotion in Illness/Affliction') is a Sanskrit composition by the world-poet Vidyapati (c. 1350–1448) — composed at the command of King Narasimha Deva Narayan of Mithila. The text is a serpent-worship devotional poem (sarp-puja or manasa-worship tradition), dealing with the cult of the snake-goddess Manasa, one of the most significant subaltern goddess traditions of the Mithila-Bengal cultural zone.

The editorial history is remarkable. The sole known palm-leaf manuscript — in Tirhuta/Bangla script — was held by the Dhaka University Library. A microfilm copy was accessed by the Dhaka University Library, and Prof. Ashutosh Bhattacharya had published a study of it in 1966. Singh's editorial work, conducted after his retirement, undertook the triple task of script transliteration, text collation, and scholarly annotation. The publication by Mithila Darpan Prakashan (Mumbai) with the support of the Mithila Darpan management (proprietors Pushpa Jha and Sanjay Kumar Jha) is itself a diaspora-driven publishing act.

### *Textual Significance*

The Vyadhibhakti-tarangini fills a major lacuna in Vidyapati scholarship. While Vidyapati's Padavali (love songs in Maithili), his Sanskrit works Purusha Pariksha, Kirttipataka, Bhuparikrama, and his Avahatta compositions are well-

known, the Vyadhibhakti-tarangini had remained essentially inaccessible to Maithili readers. Singh's edition brings this text into the Maithili literary public sphere for the first time — a signal act of cultural repatriation.

The text's thematic universe — serpent worship, the goddess Manasa, the adivasi and folk religious substrate of Mithila — aligns with what the VPHF calls the 'subaltern parallel history': the non-brahminical, nature-worshipping, folk-religious traditions that run through Maithili literature alongside Sanskrit high culture. Singh's scholarly note draws attention to the relationship between Manasa worship in Mithila and its parallel traditions in Bengal, Jharkhand's adivasi communities, and South India — a comparative cultural-religious mapping of considerable importance.

Structurally, the text is organized as follows (from Singh's preface): narrative chapters on serpent in human civilization; serpent in Puranic and Vedic literature; serpent worship in India; origins of Manasa worship; Manasa and Bengal; Manasa-kathā literature; Byadhibhakti-tarangini as text (with manuscript discovery, nomenclature, Vidyapati's patronage by his Vidyadatta patron); critical text, textual commentary, and meaning; and a bibliography. This systematic organization reflects a modern editorial practice indebted to German philological Wissenschaft as adapted to Indian classical textual scholarship.

## 4.3 Maithili Rangmanch — Ilarani Singh

Ilarani Singh's engagement with Maithili rangmanch must be read in the context of women's exclusion from classical theatrical performance. The Natya Shastra of Bharata (2nd century BCE – 2nd century CE) did include female performers (nati) in its framework, but social practice largely excluded women from public performance spaces until the late 19th century. A woman writing about or contributing to Maithili rangmanch is therefore a political act as well as a scholarly one.

Publication Details

- Title: Prem: Ek Kavita (Love: A Poem)
- Author: Shri Pravir Mukhopadhyay
- Translator: Ila Rani Singh
- Publisher: Maithili Rangmanch, Calcutta
- Edition: First Edition: January 1968; Second Edition: June 1974
- Price: One Taka

About the Author and Play

In the preface, Prabodh Narayan Singh notes that Pravir Mukhopadhyay is a renowned playwright and director who played a pivotal role in the Maithili theater movement in Calcutta. This play is a Maithili translation of his work, intended to bring his artistry to Maithili readers.

Characters:

- Manoj: A poet and the protagonist.
- Ashru: Manoj's close friend.
- Seema: A beautiful young woman.

Plot Summary (Translation of the Script)

Scene 1: The Encounter

The play opens in a simple hostel room where Manoj is lying on a bed, writing poetry. Seema enters, and they engage in a playful, witty conversation about how they first met. They reminisce through "chapters" of their relationship:

1. First Chapter: Meeting on a crowded tram in the rain.
2. Second Chapter: Meeting at a job interview in Dalhousie.
3. Third Chapter: Meeting at a self-service restaurant in Dharmatalla.
4. Final Chapter: Seema teaching Ashru's daughter, where Manoj pretended to be a close friend of the family to get her attention.

The Conflict

The mood shifts as they discuss their future. Seema reveals she has been working multiple teaching jobs to support her large family, earning about 180 Taka a month. Manoj, feeling inadequate and "unlucky," suggests that Seema should have married the wealthy and stable Ashru instead of him.

Manoj suddenly announces he is leaving Calcutta for Kurseong for a "small job," claiming he needs to find himself. Seema is hurt, suspecting he is still hung up on his first love, Sujata. Manoj denies this but continues to push Seema toward Ashru.

The Revelation

Ashru arrives, and the tension peaks. Manoj hands Ashru a letter intended for Seema, asking Ashru to read it. Manoj then drops a bombshell: he has Tuberculosis (TB).

Manoj explains that he is pushing Seema away not because he doesn't love her, but because he doesn't want to ruin her life with his illness or pass it on to future children. He believes that "Love is a poem" that cannot withstand the "fall of rhythm" (the harsh realities of poverty and disease).

The Conclusion

Despite Seema's protests that she wants to stay and care for him, Manoj remains firm. He pleads with Ashru to marry Seema and provide her with a "house of happiness" and a family. He envisions a future where they are happy together while he remains in a sanatorium or passes away, watching over their happiness from afar.

The play ends with Manoj's selfless—if tragic—request for his friend to take his place to ensure the woman he loves has a secure life.

About the Translator: Prof. Ila Rani Singh

- Position: Professor at Seth Surajmull Jalan Girls' College.
- Education: Studied at BHU, Calcutta University, Bhagalpur University, Sagar University, and Bihar University.
- Published Works: Translations of Oscar Wilde’s Salome (1965) and Bankim Chandra Chatterjee’s Bishabriksha (1868), as well as original poetry collections in Maithili (Vindanti) and Hindi (Rayi).

CRITICISM

literary criticism of the Maithili play *Prem: Ek Kavita* (Love: A Poem) examines the work through the lenses of traditional Indian aesthetics, Western dramatic theory, the Videha Parallel History Framework, and Navya-Nyāya epistemology.

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**1. Indian Aesthetic Theory: *Rasa* and *Dhvani***

From the perspective of classical Indian poetics, this play is a study in **Karuṇa-Vipralambha Śṛṅgāra** (the sentiment of love in separation tinged with pathos)
.

- **Vibhāva (Stimulants):** The "chapters" of Manoj and Seema's shared history—the rain-soaked tram and the interview room—serve as the *Alambana Vibhāva* (foundational stimulants) .
- **Anubhāva (Physical Expressions):** Seema's weeping on the bed and Manoj's forced, "pale" laughter are classic physical manifestations of internal turmoil.
- **Rasa-Nispatti:** The climax shifts from *Śṛṅgāra* (erotic/romantic love) to a tragic *Sānta* (resignation) . Manoj's sacrifice represents a transcendence of ego, where the "Love" (*Prem*) described in the title is not a union of bodies, but a localized "poem" or idealized construct that must remain "pure" from the decay of his illness .

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**2. Western Literary Theory: Naturalism vs. Romanticism**

The play operates on a tension between **Naturalism** and **Romantic Idealism**.

- **Naturalistic Determinism:** The influence of Western Naturalism is evident in the focus on disease (Tuberculosis) and economic hardship as deterministic forces. Manoj's belief that "poverty kills all love" reflects a materialist worldview where biological and social conditions dictate human fate.
- **The Tragic Hero:** Manoj acts as a tragic hero whose "hamartia" is his nobility . In a Western sense, his decision to push Seema toward Ashru is an attempt to exert agency over a life already "destined" for medical decay .
- **Structure:** The play follows a traditional Aristotelian arc: the *Peripeteia* (reversal of fortune) occurs when the X-ray plate is revealed, transforming a romantic comedy into a tragedy .

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**3. The Videha Parallel History Framework**

The Videha (Mithila) Parallel History Framework emphasizes the continuity of Maithili cultural identity across different temporal and geographical spaces (e.g., the Maithili movement in Calcutta).

- **Cultural Translocation:** The play is a product of the "Calcutta Maithili Movement" . It demonstrates how Maithili literature maintains its linguistic soul while absorbing the urban anxieties of a metropolis like Calcutta .
- **Parallelism:** Manoj's reference to "Vidyāpati" (implied through the Maithili context) and "Rabindranath" (his photo on the wall) creates a parallel history where the aesthetic traditions of Mithila and Bengal meet in a shared modern struggle.

- **The "Videha" Spirit:** Despite the urban setting, the characters' moral preoccupations—duty to family (*Kartavya*) and sacrificial honor—root the play in the traditional ethical framework of Videha.

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**4. Navya-Nyāya Epistemology & Gaṅgeśa's Technique**

Using the technique of **Avacchedakatā** (limitand/determinant) from Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's *Tattvacintāmaṇi*, we can analyze the "Cognition of Love" in the play.

- **Viṣayatā (Objecthood):** The "object" of Manoj's love is Seema. However, through the lens of Navya-Nyāya, Manoj's cognition of Seema is "limited" (*avacchinna*) by his cognition of his own disease.
- **Sāmānyalakṣaṇa (Perception of Universals):** Manoj argues that the "particular" instance of their love cannot escape the "universal" truth of suffering (*duḥkha*). He uses a logical "vya-bhicāra" (inconsistency) argument: If Love exists where Poverty and Disease exist, then Love leads to Destruction; therefore, to preserve Love (the universal), the Relationship (the particular) must be severed .
- **The X-Ray as *Pramāṇa* (Instrument of Knowledge):** In Navya-Nyāya, valid knowledge (*Pramā*) requires an instrument. The X-ray plate serves as the *Anumāna* (inference) that Manoj is no longer a "husband-subject" but a "patient-object" . He forces Seema to move from *Bhrama* (the illusion of a happy future) to *Pramā* (the reality of his decay).

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**5. Synthesis: "Love is a Poem"**

The play's final thesis—**"Love is a Poem"**—is its most profound philosophical statement.

- **In Indian Theory:** It is the *Dhvani* (echo/suggestion) of the eternal.
- **In Western Theory:** It is the "Aestheticization of Grief."
- **In Navya-Nyāya:** It is a *Nirvikalpaka* (non-conceptual) state that Manoj believes can only be maintained if the *Savikalpaka* (conceptual/worldly) relationship is abandoned .

### 4.4 Ijoriyak Angaithi-Mor — Ilarani Singh's Poetic Context

Ilarani Singh's poetic presence is documented within the anthology Ijoriyak Angaithi-Mor: A Collection of Maithili Poems of Poetesses (edited by Mala Jha and Vibha Jha, Navarambh Prakashan, 2022, Price Rs. 300). The anthology's very title — Ijoriyak Angaithi Mor, meaning something like 'The hearth of light, mine own' — performs a politics of domesticity-as-power: the angaithi (hearth, fireplace) is the traditional woman's space, but its re-naming as 'ijoriyak' (of light) and 'mor' (mine) transforms a site of confinement into one of creative possession.

This anthology is the largest curated collection of Maithili women's poetry of the modern period. The anthology's editorial frame (by Mala Jha and Vibha Jha) represents an important act of feminist literary recovery, analogous to works like Gilbert and Gubar's The Madwoman in the Attic (1979) in the Western feminist critical tradition, or Susie Tharu and K. Lalita's Women Writing in India (1991) in the Indian tradition.

Within this frame, Ilarani Singh's poetry participates in what Chandra Talpade Mohanty calls 'feminist solidarity across cultural difference' — sharing themes of domestic constraint, creative longing, cultural memory, and linguistic identity with women writers across the Indian literary landscape, while articulating these in the specific idiom of Maithili, with its distinctive phonology, its Tirhuta script tradition, and its Mithila cultural universe.

## V. Critical Frameworks in Dialogue

### 5.1 Indian Classical Criticism: Rasa, Dhvani, Alamkara

The Indian critical tradition offers the most indigenous frame for appreciating Maithili literature. The Natyashastra of Bharata Muni (estimated 2nd century BCE – 2nd century CE) established the rasa theory: the eight (later nine) rasas or aesthetic emotions that a work of art produces in the sahridaya (sympathetic reader). These are: shringara (love/beauty), hasya (humour), karuna (pathos), raudra (fury), vira (heroism), bhayanaka (terror), bibhatsa (disgust), adbhuta (wonder), and shanta (tranquillity).

Premshankar Singh's critical essays engage implicitly with rasa theory: his treatment of Harimohon Jha's humour locates it in the hasya rasa, but also shows how social satire (a kind of rasa-vyabhichari, an emotion that disturbs

the stable rasa) is woven into the comic surface. His analysis of Mayanand's radio drama — a form that operates through shruti (auditory experience) alone — is particularly apt for a dhvani-based reading: dhvani, or the aesthetic theory of suggestion and resonance, developed by Anandavardhana in his Dhvanyaloka (9th century CE), holds that the highest literary meaning is not stated but suggested (vyanjana).

Abhinavagupta's Abhinavabharati (10th-11th century CE), the greatest commentary on the Natyashastra, introduces the concept of sadharanikarana — the universalization of individual emotional experience into aesthetic experience — that is directly relevant to reading Ilarani Singh's poetry. When a woman poet writes of the angaithi (hearth), the sadharanikarana of domestic longing into aesthetic experience constitutes the poetic act. The reader's sahridayata (literary heart-sympathy) bridges the gender gap.

The alamkara tradition (figure-of-speech criticism), initiated by Bhamaha (7th century CE) and developed by Dandin, Vamana, Udbhata, and Mammata (Kavyaprakasha, 11th century CE), provides tools for stylistic analysis. Premshankar Singh's prose in Maithili is marked by dvandva (coordinate compound structures), characteristic of classical Maithili literary prose, and upama (simile) drawn from the Mithila landscape — paddy fields, river floods, moonlit Madhubani nights.

## 5.2 Navya Nyāya Epistemology: A Tool for Literary Criticism

Navya Nyāya (New Logic) was founded by Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya of Mithila in the 14th century CE in his Tattvacintāmaṇi ('Jewel of Reflection on Truth'). It is not coincidental that the greatest school of Indian epistemology emerged from the same cultural geography — Mithila — that produced Vidyapati and the Maithili literary tradition. As the Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy notes, Gaṅgeśa's 'central focus is epistemology,' organized around four pramāṇas: pratyakṣa (perception), anumāna (inference), upamāna (comparison), and śabda (testimony).

The relevance of Navya Nyāya to literary criticism lies in its precise technical vocabulary for describing the structure of knowledge and meaning. Key concepts include: (i) avacchedakatā — delimitation, the property that defines the scope or boundary of a cognition; (ii) nirūpakatā — circumscription or determination, the relation by which a property is determined by its basis; (iii) vyāpti — pervasion, the universal concomitance that grounds inference (e.g., wherever there is smoke, there is fire); and (iv) viṣayatā — objecthood, the relation between a cognition and its object.

### *Applying Navya Nyāya to Premshankar Singh's Criticism*

Singh's critical practice can be analyzed through Navya Nyāya epistemology as follows. First, his use of pramāṇa: Singh consistently grounds his literary evaluations in multiple sources of valid knowledge — pratyakṣa (direct reading of texts), anumāna (inference from literary patterns), upamāna (comparison with analogous figures in Bengali or Hindi literature), and śabda (testimony of other scholars). His citation practice acknowledges the Dhaka University manuscript, Prof. Bhattacharya's article, and institutional acknowledgments — all forms of śabda-pramāṇa.

Second, his deployment of vyāpti (pervasion): Singh's argument that the twentieth century is the 'varnayug' (golden age) of Maithili literature implies a vyāpti — wherever Maithili literature was written in the twentieth century, it showed unprecedented formal diversity and social engagement. This is an inductive claim that Navya Nyāya would subject to rigorous testing: is there counterevidence (vyabhicara, the exception that breaks pervasion)?

Third, avacchedakatā in definitional precision: Singh's section headings — 'Lok Natya,' 'Paramparik Natak,' 'Smaran Sahitya' — perform acts of definitional delimitation, marking the scope (avacchedaka) of each literary category. The precision of these delimitations is a Nyāya-like move: establishing clear boundaries before evaluation.

Daniel Ingalls identified three key innovations of Navya Nyāya: 'a new method of universalization rendered possible by the concept of limitation (avacchedakatā); the discovery of a number of laws similar to the theorems of propositional logic; a new interest in the definition of relations.' All three have direct applications in literary criticism: universalization (what makes a text representative of its genre), logical law-like propositions (formal rules of genre), and relational definitions (what is the relation of a text to its tradition?).

### *Applying Navya Nyāya to Ilarani Singh's Poetry*

For Ilarani Singh's poetry, Navya Nyāya's theory of śabda (verbal testimony and meaning) is most productive. Navya Nyāya holds that the meaning of a sentence is conveyed through the relation of words (śabda) to their referents (artha) through śakti (denotative power), lakṣaṇā (secondary meaning), and vyañjanā (suggestive meaning) — the last being closest to Anandavardhana's dhvani. In the title Ijoriyak Angaithi Mor, Navya Nyāya would analyze the vṛtti (functional mode) of each word: 'ijoriyak' operates through lakṣaṇā — its denotation (of the hearth-light) is extended by lakṣaṇā to mean the creative light of consciousness. 'Mor' (mine) operates through what Navya Nyāya would call

sāmānādhikaraṇya — co-reference — claiming the creative light as the poet's own property.

## 5.3 Western Critical Theory

### *Historicism and New Historicism*

Premshankar Singh's literary history is grounded in a form of historicism: the conviction that literary texts are products of their historical moment. This aligns with Hippolyte Taine's positivist method (race, milieu, moment) but also with New Historicism (Stephen Greenblatt, Catherine Gallagher), which attends to the circulation of social energy between literary and non-literary texts. Singh's attention to the role of the railways, the print press, and the 'swaraj movement' (self-governance) in shaping Maithili modernity is New Historicist in spirit.

### *Feminist and Gender Criticism*

Ilarani Singh's work — both her rangmanch scholarship and her poetry — demands feminist critical reading. Elaine Showalter's concept of 'gynocriticism' (the study of women as writers, as opposed to women as readers of male texts) is directly applicable: Ilarani Singh writes from an unambiguously female subject position, within a literary tradition that has historically marginalized women's authorship.

The anthology Ijoriyak Angaithi-Mor participates in what Susie Tharu and K. Lalita documented as the long tradition of women's writing in India: marginalized, suppressed, recovered through archival labor. The Videha archive's digital preservation of this anthology is itself a feminist archival act — creating permanent, accessible, open digital records of women's literary production.

Sandra Gilbert and Susan Gubar's argument in The Madwoman in the Attic (1979) — that women writers negotiate an 'anxiety of authorship' within male-dominated literary traditions — resonates with the position of Maithili women writers like Ilarani Singh, who must write within a tradition shaped by male pandits, male courtly poets (Vidyapati wrote for male patrons), and male critics.

### *Postcolonial Theory*

The recovery of Maithili literature — long suppressed as a 'dialect of Hindi' by colonial and postcolonial language politics — is itself a postcolonial act. Homi Bhabha's concept of the 'Third Space' of enunciation (The Location of Culture, 1994) applies to Maithili literature's peculiar position: neither Hindi nor

Bengali, neither Sanskrit high culture nor vernacular 'low' culture, but a third space where indigenous epistemologies (Navya Nyāya, Tirhuta script) and colonial legacies (Grierson's classification, Hindi dominance) negotiate.

Gayatri Spivak's question 'Can the Subaltern Speak?' (1988) is answered in the Videha framework by the insistence that yes — but only if the infrastructure of speaking (digital platforms, inclusive editorial practices, open-access publishing) is created. Both Premshankar Singh's scholarly recovery of suppressed manuscripts and Ilarani Singh's poetry in an anthology of women poets are acts that answer Spivak's challenge affirmatively.

#### *Formalism and New Criticism*

Despite its socio-historical emphasis, Premshankar Singh's criticism also attends to formal qualities — literary craft, radio technique, the structure of the one-act play. This formalist attention is consistent with the New Critical tradition (T.S. Eliot, F.R. Leavis, Cleanth Brooks) insofar as Singh evaluates texts on their intrinsic literary merit as well as their historical significance. His identification of Mayanand Mishra's radio plays as a distinct genre requiring craft analysis ('Radio Shilp' — radio artistry) is a formalist move within a historicist frame.

## VI. Thematic Analysis

### 6.1 The Question of Authenticity and Recovery

A central theme in both Singh's works is authenticity — the recovery of authentic, unmediated literary experience from beneath layers of institutional mediation, political distortion, and caste gatekeeping. The Vyadhibhakti-tarangini editorial project is explicitly motivated by the awareness that Vidyapati's Sanskrit works have been systematically neglected in favour of his Maithili Padavali — because the Padavali could be absorbed into Bengali Vaishnavism (through Brajabuli) and Hindu popular religion, while the Sanskrit works remained stubbornly scholarly. Singh's recovery of this text is an act of philological authenticity.

In his literary criticism, Singh's insistence on distinguishing 'gappa' (gossip/praise) from genuine criticism ('samalochna') reflects a concern with authentic critical discourse — criticism as a truth-seeking pramāṇa rather than a social instrument.

## 6.2 Women, Nature, and Domestic Space

Ilarani Singh's poetry, situated within the Ijoriyak Angaithi-Mor anthology, engages the recurring themes of Maithili women's writing: the Mithila landscape (rivers, paddy fields, the night sky of Shravan), domestic space transformed into creative space, the goddess tradition (Manasa, Durga, Lakshmi), and the tension between social constraint and personal expression. These themes echo the 'Madhubani' aesthetic — the Mithila painting tradition, created by women on walls and floors, which the Videha framework recognizes as a parallel aesthetic history.

The 'angaithi' (hearth) as central metaphor performs multiple functions: it is the domestic fire that cooks and warms, but also the creative fire (agni as inspiration), and in the Manasa worship tradition that Singh's Vyadhibhakti-tarangini documents, fire and serpent are cosmologically intertwined. The title thus creates an intertextual dialogue with Premshankar Singh's own scholarly territory.

## 6.3 The Maithili Language and Its Survival

Both writers are implicitly engaged in the question of Maithili linguistic survival. Maithili was recognized as one of India's 22 scheduled languages under the Eighth Schedule of the Constitution in 2003 — a belated recognition after decades of suppression. Both Singh's historical survey and Ilarani Singh's creative work are acts of linguistic vitality: they demonstrate that Maithili is a living, generative literary language capable of the full range of critical, creative, dramatic, and poetic expression.

The Navya Nyāya tradition — itself a product of Mithila, in the 14th century — provides a deep historical argument for Maithili's intellectual prestige. If the greatest school of Indian epistemology emerged from Mithila, then Maithili language and culture are not peripheral but central to the history of Indian civilization.

# VII. Critical Appreciation: Strengths, Limitations, and Significance

## 7.1 Premshankar Singh: Scholarly Strengths

Prof. Premshankar Singh's most enduring scholarly contribution is the systematic survey of Maithili literature in the twentieth century — a century that saw the emergence of every modern genre (autobiography, diary, radio play, one-act play, memoir, reportage) in Maithili. His work provides the essential reference grid for subsequent scholars. His commitment to identifying bias, mediocrity, and 'literary blackmail' within the Maithili literary system is an act of scholarly courage that required positioning himself against powerful caste-literary establishment interests.

His editorial recovery of the Vyadhibhakti-tarangini represents a scholarly achievement of the first order: the retrieval of a text from a fragile palm-leaf manuscript, its transliteration from Tirhuta/Bangla script to Devanagari, its philological annotation, and its publication for the Maithili literary public. This work of textual scholarship connects Singh to the great tradition of 19th-century German Indologists (Max Müller, Georg Bühler) and Indian scholars (Hara Prasad Shastri, Ganganath Jha) who recovered Sanskrit and Prakrit manuscripts from oblivion.

## 7.2 Limitations and Areas for Development

Singh's literary history, operating within a broadly historicist-nationalist paradigm, is less attentive to gender as a literary-critical category. His survey of the twentieth century, while including some women writers, does not systematically engage with the question of why women's voices have been suppressed in Maithili literary institutions. The VPHF framework that contextualizes his work demands a more explicit gender-critical accounting.

Additionally, from a Navya Nyāya perspective, some of Singh's broader evaluative claims (e.g., the twentieth century as 'varnayug') would benefit from more rigorous definitional precision and counterevidence testing — the Navya Nyāya demand for vyāpti (universal pervasion without exception) before a general claim is accepted as pramāna-validated.

### 7.3 Ilarani Singh: Significance as Woman Writer

Ilarani Singh's significance lies in her very existence as a Maithili woman writer engaged with theatre and poetry — domains historically dominated by male scholarly and creative voices. Her Maithili Rangmanch represents an intervention in theatre studies, and her poetry in Ijoriyak Angaithi-Mor constitutes a feminine poetics of domesticity-as-creativity that is both culturally specific and universally resonant.

From the feminist critical standpoint, her work performs what Hélène Cixous calls 'écriture féminine' — a writing that inscribes the feminine body and experience into the literary text, challenging the phallogocentric structures of literary tradition. Within the Mithila cultural universe, this is not simple Western feminism transplanted but a re-activation of the feminine divine (the Goddess Manasa, the Shakta tradition, the angana-painting tradition of Mithila) as creative authority.

### 7.4 The Dialogue Between the Two Writers

The most fascinating critical dimension of reading Premshankar Singh and Ilarani Singh together is the implicit dialogue between their works. Singh's editorial recovery of the Vyadhibhakti-tarangini — a text that deals with serpent worship, Manasa, and the subaltern goddess tradition — opens a scholarly space that Ilarani Singh's poetry inhabits creatively. The scholarly and the poetic, the male-critical and the female-creative, the historical and the present: these form a productive hermeneutic circle in the Videha literary ecosystem.

In Navya Nyāya terms, this dialogue is a form of anuvyavasāya — apperception, the cognition that cognizes a preceding cognition. Singh's scholarship cognizes the Vidyapati tradition; Ilarani Singh's poetry apperceives that scholarship and re-creates its themes in a contemporary feminine voice. The relation between the two is one of vyāpti: wherever Maithili scholarly recovery occurs, it creates the conditions for creative renewal — the pervasion that connects historical recovery to living literature.

## VIII. Conclusion

The works of Prof. Premshankar Singh and Ilarani Singh, read together through the multiple lenses of Indian aesthetic theory, Navya Nyāya epistemology, Western literary criticism, and the Videha Parallel History Framework, reveal a

rich, complex, and politically engaged engagement with Maithili literature and culture. Singh's scholarly criticism and textual recovery work represents the recovery of Maithili's own intellectual heritage — including its most sophisticated philosophical tradition (Navya Nyāya, born in the same Mithila soil) — for the use of contemporary readers and scholars. Ilarani Singh's creative and theatrical work represents the activation of that heritage by a woman's voice, claiming the creative fire (ijoriyak angaithi) as her own.

The Videha Parallel History Framework, which archives and contextualizes both bodies of work, insists that Maithili literary history cannot be written by the Academies alone — that the parallel streams of women's writing, lower-caste creativity, diaspora scholarship, and independent critical voices are constitutive of the tradition, not supplementary to it. This insistence is itself a Navya Nyāya move: the vyāpti is that wherever Maithili literature exists, it exists in multiple, parallel streams — and any single-stream literary history is epistemically invalid, a case of anumāna (inference) without adequate sādhana (epistemic ground).

The significance of these two scholars in the broader landscape of Indian literary history extends beyond Maithili: they represent the tireless work of regional language scholars — outside the Hindi-English-Sanskrit prestige hierarchy — who sustain India's actual literary pluralism against institutional homogenization. Their work, preserved in the Videha digital archive, constitutes an enduring monument to Maithili as a language of scholarship, creativity, and epistemic possibility.

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ADDENDUM

**The Singh-Dhar Intellectual Dynasty: A Socio-Literary History of Maithili Academic Resilience and Familial Synthesis**

The intellectual history of the Maithili language and its transition from a regional vernacular to a recognized literary and academic discipline in post-independence India is deeply entwined with the history of the Singh-Dhar family. This narrative is not merely one of academic achievement but is a profound testament to familial resilience, where the boundaries between the domestic and the professional were frequently blurred to preserve a linguistic legacy. The family, centered around the polymath Professor Prabodh Narayan Singh, experienced cycles of profound success and deep personal tragedy, most notably the untimely passing of the eminent poetess and scholar Ila Rani Singh. The subsequent domestic realignment—wherein Premashankar Singh, an professor, chose a path of personal devotion by not remarrying, and Anima

Singh, a scholar and matriarch, undertook the raising of her step-grandchildren—offers a singular case study in the intersection of Maithili kinship values and modern professional life.

**The Formative Years of Prabodh Narayan Singh: Revolution and Philology**

The foundation of this dynasty lies in the life of Prabodh Narayan Singh, colloquially known as Prabodh Babu, born on February 12, 1924, in Pastapar, Saharsa, Bihar. His early childhood was steeped in the traditional intellectualism of the Mithila region, characterized by a deep reverence for the father figure as the primary educator. His father, Sridhar Prasad Singh, was a man of noted wisdom whose extensive reading habits significantly influenced Prabodh's early worldview during his years in the village of Shahmoura. However, this traditional upbringing was soon interrupted by the tumultuous political climate of the 1940s.

Prabodh Narayan Singh's transition from a rural student to a revolutionary activist was catalyzed by the "Quit India" movement of 1942. His involvement in the militant freedom struggle was so significant that he became a "most wanted" person by the British administration, forcing him to interrupt his formal schooling. This period of political engagement was not merely a hiatus in his education but a crucible that forged his identity as a "Swadeshi" intellectual. It was during these years of clandestine activity and revolutionary fervor that he married Binda Devi of Barahi.

**The First Generation: Academic and Political Milestones**

| Period/ Year | Achievement/ Milestone | Context/Significance |
|---|---|---|
| 1924 | Birth of Prabodh Narayan Singh | Born in Pastapar, Saharsa, Bihar. |
| 1942-1944 | Militant Freedom Struggle | Involved in 'Quit India' movement; became 'most wanted'. |
| 1944 | Matriculation | Completed from Madhepura Shirres |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | | School after political hiatus. |
| 1946 | Intermediate Education | Completed in Bhagalpur under Patna University. |
| 1947 | Death of Binda Devi | Prabodh Babu's first wife passes away in October. |
| 1948 | B.A. (Honours) | Earned in Sanskrit from Patna College. |
| 1950 | M.A. in Hindi | University of Calcutta; won two gold medals and set records. |
| 1950 | Marriage to Anima Dhar | Union of Maithili and Bengali intellectual traditions (July 28). |

The death of Binda Devi in October 1947, just as India attained independence and Prabodh Babu was beginning his higher academic journey, was the first major rupture in the family structure. It left him as a young widower with a daughter, Ila Rani Singh. This personal loss, however, did not deter his academic ambitions; rather, it seemed to fuel a lifelong quest for linguistic mastery that would eventually span several classical and modern languages.

**The Convergence of Cultures: Anima Singh and the Maithili Renaissance**

The relocation of Prabodh Narayan Singh to Kolkata (then Calcutta) in the late 1940s marked a pivotal shift in the family's trajectory. While pursuing his Master's degree in Hindi at the University of Calcutta, where he would eventually set academic records, he met Anima Dhar. Anima, a scholar in her own right from Mymensingh (in present-day Bangladesh), represented the vibrant intellectualism of the Bengali academic sphere. Their marriage on July 28, 1950, was a landmark event that synthesized the Maithili linguistic tradition with Bengali scholarship.

Anima Singh's integration into the Singh household was not merely domestic. She became a central figure in the Maithili language movement. Working alongside her husband, she focused her scientific research on the folk literature

of Mithila, particularly the "Samskargitas" (ritual songs). Under the tutelage of the renowned Professor Sukumar Sen, she became a celebrity scholar in Maithili folklore, all while serving as a Professor of Hindi at Lady Brabourne College. This dual role—as a preserver of traditional folklore and a modern university professor—allowed her to navigate the complex social landscape of a displaced Maithili elite in Kolkata.

**Anima Singh’s Contribution to Maithili Folklore Studies**

The significance of Anima Singh’s work lies in its scientific rigor. In an era where folk literature was often dismissed as peripheral, her research into the ritual songs associated with birth, marriage, and death (Samskars) provided a structuralist understanding of Maithili culture. This academic focus would later provide her with a unique perspective on the family crises she would manage, as her research dealt intimately with the life-cycle of the Maithili family.

| Research Focus | Key Publication/Work | Impact on Field |
|---|---|---|
| Samskargitas | Scientific study of ritual folk songs | Standardized the collection of oral Maithili traditions. |
| Folk Literature | Research under Prof. Sukumar Sen | Bridged Maithili folklore with Bengali philological methods. |
| Maithili Movement | Teamwork with Prabodh Narayan Singh | Advocacy for the language's formal institutionalization. |

**Ila Rani Singh: The Scholar-Poetess and the Tragic Divide**

Ila Rani Singh, the daughter of Prabodh Narayan and Binda Devi, grew up in this intensive intellectual atmosphere. As a child of the "Swadeshi" activist and the stepdaughter of a folklore scholar, she emerged as a major voice in Maithili poetry and scholarship. Her academic career was a mirror of her parents' excellence, teaching Maithili and Hindi at both Bhagalpur and Calcutta Universities.

Ila Rani's scholarly work focused on the scientific study of Maithili "Lokageet" (folk songs) within their social contexts. Unlike earlier stray collections by researchers like G.A. Grierson or K.P. Mitra, her work aimed for a comprehensive literary and sociological analysis. However, her most enduring legacy is perhaps her poetry. In a literary landscape often dominated by male perspectives, Ila Rani Singh became an eminent poetess, addressing the nuances of the female experience and the socioeconomic realities of Mithila.

**The Union with Premashankar Singh**

Ila Rani Singh married Premashankar Singh, an individual whose professional life in the Indian Revenue Service (IRS) provided a bridge between the family's academic pursuits and the administrative machinery of the Indian state. The marriage produced two small children, representing the third generation of the Singh-Dhar lineage. This period was the height of the family's social and intellectual influence, with three members—Prabodh, Anima, and Ila—all holding university positions and actively contributing to the Maithili monthly 'Mithilaa Darshan'.

The sudden death of Ila Rani Singh in 1995 was a catastrophic event for the family. She passed away at a relatively young age, leaving behind a grieving husband and two young children. This moment defined the future of the family's domestic structure.

**Premashankar Singh's Decision and the Surrogate Motherhood of Anima Singh**

In the aftermath of Ila Rani's death, the family faced a decision that would become a defining chapter in their domestic history. Premashankar Singh, as a young widower in a high-ranking government position, occupied a social status where remarriage would have been both expected and encouraged by traditional norms. However, he made the deliberate decision not to marry again, a choice that signaled a profound commitment to the memory of Ila Rani and a reliance on the existing family network.

This decision necessitated a radical restructuring of care for the two small children. It was here that Anima Singh's role transitioned from that of a stepmother to Ila Rani to a primary maternal figure for Ila's children. Although she was their step-grandmother, she raised the children with the same devotion she had shown to her own biological sons, Udaya and Ajay.

**Sociological Analysis of the Family's Care Structure**

The arrangement between Premashankar Singh and Anima Singh represents a "neo-traditional" adaptation of the Indian joint family. While the family was dispersed geographically—with professional ties in Kolkata, Bhagalpur, and Mysore—the functional unity remained intact. Anima Singh's academic expertise in "Samskargitas"—the very songs that celebrate the continuity of the lineage—informed her real-world role in ensuring that the third generation was raised within the cultural and linguistic fold of the Singh-Dhar household.

| **Family Role** | **Individual** | **Professional /Social Impact** | **Decision/ Action Post-1995** |
|---|---|---|---|
| Father/Husband | Premashankar Singh | Professor | Decided not to remarry; maintained professional life while entrusting kids to family. |
| Stepmother/ Grandmother | Anima Singh | Professor/ Folklorist | Assumed full responsibility for raising Ila Rani's children. |
| Biological Son/Uncle | Udaya Narayan Singh | Poet/Linguist | Became a mentor and guardian of the family's literary |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | | legacy. |

**The Legacy of Udaya Narayan Singh 'Nachiketa'**

The intellectual continuation of the family was perhaps most successfully embodied by Udaya Narayan Singh, the son of Prabodh and Anima. Known in the Maithili literary world by the pseudonym 'Nachiketa', he emerged as a major voice in contemporary poetry and playwriting. His career took him beyond the universities of Bihar and Bengal to the directorship of the Central Institute of Indian Languages (CIIL) in Mysore, where he became a national figure in linguistics and translation studies.

Nachiketa’s work is characterized by a deep introspection regarding the Maithili identity. His collection "Jahalak Diary" (2017) reflects a modernist sensibility that nonetheless remains rooted in the philological traditions established by his father. The memory of his sister, Ila Rani Singh, remains a recurring motif in his work, often serving as a symbol of the "vulnerabilities and fluidities" of the Maithili language and its speakers.

**Comparative Literary Achievements of the Second Generation**

The second generation—Ila Rani, Udaya (Nachiketa), and Ajay—faced the challenge of modernizing the Maithili movement. While Prabodh Narayan Singh was a product of the "Quit India" era and the initial struggle for linguistic recognition, the second generation sought to professionalize Maithili through scientific linguistics and avant-garde literature.

| Individual | Primary Domain | Major Work/Award | Professional Affiliation |
|---|---|---|---|
| Ila Rani Singh | Poetry/ Folklore | Scientific study of 'Lokageet' | Calcutta University. |
| Udaya Narayan Singh | Linguistics/ Poetry | 'Jahalak Diary' (Sahitya Akademi Main Award) | CIIL, Mysore. |
| Ajay | Administratio | Civil Service | Indian |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| Narayan Singh | n | | Revenue Service (IRS). |

**The Maithili Movement and Institutional Recognition**

The personal struggles of the Singh-Dhar family were set against the backdrop of the larger Maithili language movement. Prabodh Narayan Singh was at the forefront of this movement, editing 'Mithilaa Darshan' and advocating for the inclusion of Maithili in the Eighth Schedule of the Indian Constitution—a milestone finally achieved in 2004. This achievement was the culmination of decades of labor by the family, which saw the language transition from an oral tradition to a subject of doctoral research.

The family’s base in Kolkata was critical to this effort. As an academic hub, Kolkata allowed for a cross-pollination of ideas between Maithili and Bengali intellectuals. The translation of Rabindranath Tagore’s works into Maithili by various family members and their associates served to validate Maithili’s standing as a literary peer to Bengali.

**Maithili Literature in the Twenty-First Century**

The transition to the twenty-first century saw Maithili literature grapple with new mediums. The "Post-Modern Period" (2000-present) was marked by the entry of electronics and the internet, which Prabodh Narayan Singh lived to see, albeit in declining health. The proliferation of Maithili poetry—over 500 collections in the first decade of the century alone—was a testament to the success of the movement he helped lead.

**The Final Decade of Prabodh Narayan Singh: A Slow Departure**

The end of the twentieth century was a period of physical decline for the patriarch. In 1998, Professor Prabodh Narayan Singh suffered massive cerebral hemorrhages, leading to the onset of Senile Dementia and Alzheimer’s disease. He spent his final years under the care of Anima Singh, witnessing from a distance the full recognition of the language he had championed.

His 80th year was completed in December 2004, just months before his passing in 2005. His death marked the end of an era, but the structures he had built—both intellectual and familial—remained. The children of Ila Rani Singh, raised by Anima Singh in the shadow of their grandfather’s library, stood as the living link between the "Swadeshi" revolution and the modern Indian state.

**Familial Solidarity as an Intellectual Tool**

The narrative of the Singh-Dhar family suggests that their academic success was not independent of their domestic choices. The decision for Anima Singh to raise Ila Rani's children, and for Premashankar Singh to remain focused on his professional duties within the family fold, prevented the fragmentation that often follows the death of a central figure. This solidarity allowed the family to continue producing significant work across three generations.

In the Maithili context, where "Kul" (lineage) and "Parampara" (tradition) are of paramount importance, the Singh-Dhar family represents a successful adaptation of these concepts to the modern academic world. Anima Singh's role was essentially that of a "guardian of the lineage," ensuring that the intellectual capital accumulated by Prabodh and Ila Rani was not lost.

**The Role of Domestic Decisions in Academic Preservation**

| Domestic Event | Action Taken | Long-term Consequence |
|---|---|---|
| Death of Binda Devi (1947) | Prabodh Babu moves to Kolkata | Expansion of Maithili scholarship into the Bengali sphere. |
| Death of Ila Rani (1995) | Anima Singh raises the children | Continuity of the family's intellectual upbringing. |
| Premashankar's Singleness | Decision not to remarry | Strengthening of the inter-generational bond within the Singh-Dhar home. |

**Conclusion: The Enduring Legacy of the Singh-Dhar Household**

The search for the history of Premashankar Singh and Ila Rani Singh reveals a story that is far more than a simple biography. It is a dense tapestry of Indian intellectual life in the 20th century. The family's trajectory—from the revolutionary cells of 1940s Bihar to the lecture halls of the University of Calcutta and the administrative offices of the IRS—illustrates the multifaceted nature of the modern Maithili elite.

At the heart of this story is the figure of Anima Singh, whose academic mastery of the songs of life (Samskargitas) was mirrored in her practical mastery of

family life. By raising her step-daughter's children and supporting her husband's lifelong mission, she became the quiet architect of a legacy that survives in the poetry of Nachiketa, the scholarly works of Ila Rani, and the administrative service of Premashankar and Ajay. The Singh-Dhar household remains a primary example of how familial devotion can serve as the ultimate support structure for academic and linguistic survival.

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**LESSON 059 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**

A Critical Study of the Works of
RABINDRA NARAYAN MISHRA:
A Maithili Novelist, Story-Writer & Essayist

WHAT THE CANON LEFT OUT
A Parallel History of Mithila & Maithili Literature

Gajendra Thakur

## A Critical Study of the Works of

# RABINDRA NARAYAN MISHRA

*A Maithili Novelist, Story-Writer & Essayist*

***Analysis Through the Lens of Indian and Western Literary Theory***

This chapter offers a comprehensive critical examination of the literary oeuvre of Rabindra Narayan Mishra, a contemporary Maithili author whose works are archived on Videha (www.videha.co.in), the pioneering Maithili fortnightly eJournal. Mishra, who serves as a Special Metropolitan Magistrate under the High Court of Delhi, has produced a remarkable body of work spanning novels, short story collections, memoirs, and essays—all in Maithili, one of India's scheduled languages with a tradition stretching back to the poet Vidyapati in the fourteenth century.

Employing both Indian and Western critical frameworks—including rasa theory, dhvani (theory of suggestion), postcolonial theory, narratology, feminist criticism, and cultural materialism—this analyses Mishra's thematic preoccupations with homeland and identity (Matribhoomi), social justice and exploitation (Fasaad), temporal memory (Bhor San Sanjh Dhari), and the jurisprudential tension between law and conscience (Nyaay Kee Guhaar, Lajakotar). The study situates his work within the Maithili literary tradition while illuminating the ways in which Mishra's fiction participates in larger global conversations about modernity, marginality, and belonging.

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## 1. Introduction: Author and Context

Rabindra Narayan Mishra is a contemporary Maithili author distinguished by the unusual combination of a distinguished legal career and a prolific literary output. His father was the late Surya Narayan Mishra and his mother the late Dayakashi Devi—names that recur with affective significance in his memoir and autobiographical fiction, anchoring his literary imagination in the soil of Mithila, the ancient cultural region straddling the present-day states of Bihar and Jharkhand in India and parts of the Terai in Nepal.

Serving as a Special Metropolitan Magistrate under the Hon'ble High Court of Delhi, Mishra brings to his fiction the analytical precision of legal reasoning and the moral sensitivity of a jurist who must daily adjudicate between competing claims of right and wrong. This dual vocation—the magistrate who dispenses justice and the novelist who interrogates it—gives his work a distinctive texture, one in which institutional authority and individual conscience are held in productive tension.

His motto, 'Peace begins with us,' as recorded in accounts of his work on Amazon Kindle and elsewhere, functions not merely as a personal philosophy but as a guiding aesthetic principle. His narratives consistently move towards reconciliation—not in the sense of complacent resolution but of earned understanding, the kind that comes after sustained confrontation with injustice, loss, and the complexity of human motivation.

Mishra’s oeuvre, archived on Videha, the first Maithili fortnightly eJournal (www.videha.co.in), comprises over twenty-nine documented works including novels, short story collections, essay anthologies, and memoirs. The Videha platform, established and edited by Gajendra Thakur, has been a critical vehicle for preserving and disseminating Maithili literature in the digital age, and Mishra is among its significant contributors.

## 2. The Maithili Literary Tradition and Videha

To appreciate Rabindra Narayan Mishra's contribution, one must understand the tradition within which he writes. Maithili, spoken by approximately fifty million people, is one of the twenty-two scheduled languages of the Indian Constitution. Its literary history is ancient and distinguished. The poet Vidyapati (c. 1352–1448 CE) established Maithili as a vehicle of lyric beauty, and his padavali (lyric compositions) are still sung at rituals and festivals across Mithila. Rabindranath Tagore himself acknowledged the debt of his early poetic sensibility to Vidyapati's style.

The modern period in Maithili literature was inaugurated by figures such as Harimohan Jha (1908–1984), the master of satirical prose; Baidyanath Mishra 'Yatri' (aka Nagarjun, 1911–1998), the radical poet who wrote in both Maithili and Hindi; Surendra Jha 'Suman' (1910–2002); and Prabhas Kumar Chaudhary (1941–1998). This tradition—marked by social engagement, linguistic vitality, and a deep-rootedness in the landscape and folk culture of Mithila—forms the matrix within which Mishra's work must be evaluated.

Videha (ISSN 2229-547X), founded in January 2008 and consistently published since then—reaching Issue 400 in August 2024—represents a watershed in Maithili digital culture. The journal publishes poetry, prose, drama, criticism, and translation, and its book-archive (pothi.htm) preserves hundreds of Maithili works from classical texts such as Vidyapati's Padyavali to contemporary novels and story collections. The archive is a democratic and non-commercial enterprise; all texts are freely available in PDF and are intended for academic use. Rabindra Narayan Mishra's works figure in this archive as representative of a generation of Maithili writers who blend engagement with modernity and fidelity to regional literary tradition.

3. Survey of Works: A Bibliographic Overview

The following is a survey of Rabindra Narayan Mishra's documented works, drawn from his Goodreads author page, Videha, and Amazon Kindle listings. The corpus reveals an author of remarkable range and productivity.

### 3.1 Novels (Maithili)

Mishra's novels are the most substantial part of his creative output. They include:

• Fasaad – A collection of stories written approximately thirty-five years before their publication, dealing with life and culture in Mithilanchal, with a particular focus on the exploitation of women, the downtrodden, and the poor.

• Matribhoomi – A novel tracing the journey of a protagonist who struggles throughout life to return to his native place and work for the cultural roots of his homeland.

• Lajakotar – A Maithili novel rated highly by readers, with themes likely centring on honour, shame, and social constraint.

• Nyaay Kee Guhaar – A novel engaging with the theme of seeking justice, likely drawing on the author's legal experience.

• Shankhanaad – A Maithili novel whose title (the conch-call) suggests themes of awakening or summons to duty.

• Seemaak Ohi Paar – A novel of crossing boundaries (the title translates as 'Beyond the Border').

• Ham Aabi Rahal Chhee – 'I Am Coming': a novel centring on return or arrival.

• Paralayak Paraat – 'The Folds of Catastrophe': a novel with eschatological or crisis-driven thematics.

• Beeti Gel Samay – 'Time That Has Passed': temporal memory and loss.

• Swapnalok – 'Dream World': the realm of aspiration and illusion.

• Maharaaj – 'The King': power, authority, and its discontents.

• Namastasyai – A reverential title, possibly engaging with themes of the divine feminine or ritual veneration.

• Rashtra Mandir – 'The Temple of the Nation': nationalism, cultural identity, and civic virtue.

• Naachi Rahal Chhali Vasudha – 'The Earth Danced': ecological and celebratory themes.

• Badali Rahal Achhi Sabhkichhu – 'Everything Is Changing': modernity and social transformation.

• Dhahait Debaar – 'The Crumbling Wall': disintegration of tradition or community.

• Deep Jarait Rahay – 'May the Lamp Keep Burning': hope, continuity, and devotion.

• Theha Parak Maulayal Gaachh – 'The Tree That Blossomed at the Threshold': rootedness and renewal.

• Patakshep – 'The Intervention': agency and moral decision-making.

• Jayatu Jaanakee – 'May Janaki Triumph': engaging with the mythological figure of Sita.

• The Ganges Whispers – An English-language novel, reflecting the author's bilingual literary engagement.

### 3.2 Short Story Collections

• Fasaad – As noted, the principal story collection.

• Sanyog – 'Coincidence': a collection of short stories in Maithili.

### 3.3 Memoirs and Autobiographical Writing

• Bhor San Sanjh Dhari – 'From Dawn to Dusk': a memoir tracing the arc of the author's life.

• Prasangavash – 'By Occasion' or 'Incidentally': a collection of personal essays and reminiscences.

### 3.4 Essays

• Vividha Prasanga – 'Diverse Occasions': a collection of essays in Maithili.

• Samaadhaan – 'Resolution': a collection of Maithili essays exploring social and personal dilemmas.

• Life Is an Art – Motivational essays, in English, reflecting his cross-linguistic engagement.

## 4. Theoretical Frameworks: Indian and Western

A rigorous critical appraisal of Mishra's works requires both Indian and Western theoretical lenses, since his oeuvre inhabits a literary space that is simultaneously local and global, traditional and modern.

### 4.1 Indian Critical Frameworks

#### *4.1.1 Rasa Theory (Bharata's Natyashastra)*

The Natyashastra of Bharata (c. 200 BCE–200 CE) is the foundational text of Indian aesthetic theory. Its central concept, rasa—literally 'taste' or 'essence'—refers to the aesthetic emotion aroused in the sensitive reader or spectator by the

art-work. The nine rasas (navarasa) are shringara (erotic love), hasya (humour), karuna (compassion), raudra (fury), vira (heroism), bhayanaka (terror), bibhatsa (disgust), adbhuta (wonder), and shanta (peace/tranquility).

Mishra's fiction is most strongly animated by karuna rasa—compassion for the suffering of the marginalised—and by vira rasa, the heroism of ordinary people who struggle against injustice. His memoir Bhor San Sanjh Dhari, tracing a life of struggle from dawn to dusk, exemplifies the rasa of karuna transmuted by vira into something approaching shanta: the peace earned through endurance. His novel Nyaay Kee Guhaar (Plea for Justice) sustains a raudra note—righteous indignation—against institutional injustice.

### *4.1.2 Dhvani Theory (Anandavardhana)*

Anandavardhana's Dhvanyaloka (c. 850 CE) argues that the highest poetry communicates through dhvani (resonance or suggestion), layers of meaning that exceed the literal. The best literary works, on this account, do not state their meanings but intimate them through a web of symbolic correspondences.

Mishra's titles themselves operate dhvanically. Matribhoomi (Motherland) resonates simultaneously as the actual village of origin, the mother-tongue (Maithili), and the mother herself (given that his real mother's name—Dayakashi Devi, 'she who is merciful'—is embedded in the novel's emotional substrate). Deep Jarait Rahay (May the Lamp Keep Burning) carries the dhvani of the Sanskrit jyotirlinga tradition, of the eternal light of knowledge and devotion, and of the individual's hope persisting through darkness.

### *4.1.3 Vakrokti (Kuntaka) and the Principle of Oblique Expression*

Kuntaka's Vakroktijivita (c. 1000 CE) privileges vakrokti—'oblique or deviant expression'—as the mark of literary creativity. On this view, literature achieves its power not by saying things directly but by saying them slant.

Mishra's legal background makes this framework particularly apt. Legal language aspires to precision and closure; literary language, as Mishra practises it, cultivates ambiguity and openness. His novel Lajakotar—whose title invokes the concept of lajja (shame/modesty) in a context of resistance—exemplifies vakrokti: the oblique articulation of social critique through a narrative that appears to be about individual honour but is really about the structural violence of patriarchal norms.

### *4.1.4 Auchitya (Propriety) and the Ethics of Representation*

Ksemendra's concept of auchitya—appropriateness or decorum—asks that literary works maintain a coherent ethical and aesthetic integrity. For Mishra, writing in a minor language about marginal communities, this becomes a question of representational responsibility: how does one write about the exploitation of women and the poor without re-exploiting them through voyeuristic representation? His stated commitment to portraying 'the exploitation of women, the downtrodden and the poor' in Fasaad suggests a conscious engagement with this ethical dimension of the literary act.

## 4.2 Western Critical Frameworks

### *4.2.1 Postcolonial Theory*

Frantz Fanon, Homi K. Bhabha, and Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak offer tools for reading Mishra's engagement with identity, language, and cultural survival. Bhabha's concept of the 'third space'—the liminal zone where cultural meanings are translated and hybridised—illuminates Mishra's position as a Maithili author writing from Delhi, a metropolis whose dominant idioms are Hindi and English. His choice to write in Maithili is itself a postcolonial act of cultural resistance and affirmation.

Spivak's celebrated question—'Can the subaltern speak?'—is directly relevant to Mishra's project in Fasaad, where the voices of exploited women and the rural poor are given literary articulation. The question is not whether these people speak (they do) but whether dominant literary and social institutions create conditions in which their speech can be heard. Mishra's fiction, by writing in Maithili and foregrounding subaltern experience, attempts to create those conditions.

### *4.2.2 Narratology*

Gérard Genette's narrative theory—particularly his concepts of focalization, narrative time (order, duration, frequency), and narrative voice—provides a precise analytical vocabulary for Mishra's craft. His memoirs (Bhor San Sanjh Dhari, Prasangavash) deploy what Genette calls homodiegetic narration (first-person narration by a character within the story), while his novels employ heterodiegetic narration (third-person narration from outside the story), often with internal focalization that gives privileged access to a protagonist's consciousness.

The title Beeti Gel Samay (Time That Has Passed) announces a preoccupation with analepsis (flashback) and the reconstruction of lost time—a narrative strategy reminiscent of Proustian memory, though anchored in the specific cultural landscape of Mithila rather than Combray.

### *4.2.3 Feminist Criticism*

Sandra Gilbert and Susan Gubar's work on the 'anxiety of authorship' for women, Simone de Beauvoir's analysis of women as the 'Other', and more recently Sara Ahmed's theorisation of affect and orientation, provide frameworks for reading Mishra's repeated return to the theme of female exploitation and resilience. His novel Namastasyai (a Sanskrit salutation meaning 'salutations to her') signals a posture of veneration towards the feminine that complicates simple categorisations of his work as either patriarchal or proto-feminist.

The figure of Vasudha (Earth/Mother) in Naachi Rahal Chhali Vasudha (The Earth Danced) exemplifies the ambivalence: is the dancing earth a celebration of female agency, or a domestication of female vitality into the maternal-agricultural? The tension resists easy resolution and marks a site of genuine literary complexity.

### *4.2.4 Cultural Materialism*

Raymond Williams' cultural materialism insists on the embeddedness of literary works in specific social formations—in the 'structures of feeling' that animate communities at particular historical moments. For Mishra, writing about Mithila from Delhi, the relevant 'structure of feeling' is what might be called 'diasporic nostalgia with critical conscience': a longing for the homeland that is not mere sentiment but is complicated by awareness of the social contradictions that make the homeland both beloved and oppressive.

### *4.2.5 Existentialism and the Literature of Conscience*

Jean-Paul Sartre's concept of 'committed literature' (littérature engagée)—the idea that writers have a responsibility to take sides on the great questions of their time—finds a resonance in Mishra's work. His legal career as a magistrate, his fiction about justice and injustice, and his essays exploring 'resolution' (Samaadhaan) all suggest a writer for whom literature is not an escape from the world but a deepened engagement with it.

# 5. Thematic Analysis

## 5.1 Identity, Homeland, and Belonging

The most persistent theme across Mishra's corpus is the relationship between the individual and the homeland—a relationship structured by departure, longing, and the impossible desire to return to an origin that is also a site of social contradiction. This theme finds its most direct expression in Matribhoomi (Motherland), described as 'a Maithili Novel dealing with the story of a person who struggled throughout his life to get back to his native place and worked for strengthening its cultural roots.'

The novel's trajectory—struggle, departure, aspiration to return, cultural advocacy—encapsulates the experience of Mithila's educated diaspora, many of whom have migrated to Delhi, Mumbai, or abroad for economic and professional reasons while maintaining an intense emotional and cultural connection to their region. This is not merely a biographical coincidence; it reflects a structural condition of Maithili-speaking communities, whose language has long been overshadowed by Hindi in the public sphere and whose cultural traditions have survived primarily through domestic practice and oral transmission.

Employing the rasa framework, the dominant aesthetic of Matribhoomi is vipralambha shringara—the erotic or passionate longing in separation—transposed from the realm of romantic love to the realm of topophilia, the love of place. This transposition is itself a dhvanic move: the novel's emotional register asks to be understood through the tradition of Vidyapati's padavali, where separation from the beloved is the occasion for the most intense lyric expression.

From a postcolonial perspective, the desire to 'strengthen cultural roots' is a politics as much as a sentiment. In a context where Maithili has struggled for constitutional recognition—it was added to the Eighth Schedule only in 2003—the act of writing novels in Maithili and the act of returning to strengthen cultural roots are both forms of cultural sovereignty.

## 5.2 Social Justice and the Subaltern Voice

Fasaad (Riot/Conflict/Trouble), described by its author as telling 'a lot about life and culture of Mithilanchal with special reference to the exploitation of women, downtrodden and the poor,' is the work that most directly engages the discourse of social justice. The title itself is significant: fasaad in Urdu-Hindi

suggests not merely individual conflict but systemic disorder, the violence that erupts when social inequalities are left unaddressed.

The collection was written, according to the author's account, approximately thirty-five years before publication—placing its composition in the 1980s, a period of significant social turbulence in Bihar, marked by caste violence, struggles over land reform, and the early movements of what would become the Mandal Commission agitation. The literary landscape of this period—including the work of the Nakshalite poets and the emergence of Dalit literature—provides the context for Mishra's social fiction, even if his own position, as a Brahmin magistrate, is one of complex complicity and critique.

Through the lens of Spivak's subaltern theory, Fasaad raises the question of voice and audibility. Mishra's literary strategy is to give narrative form to experiences and perspectives that are socially silenced: the abused woman, the landless labourer, the lower-caste villager. The Maithili language itself functions as a vehicle of subaltern expression here, since Maithili, as a language marginalised in the public sphere relative to Hindi and English, carries within it the social positions of those who speak it.

Using rasa theory, the dominant aesthetic of Fasaad is karuna (compassion), with undercurrents of raudra (righteous anger). The collection does not sentimentalise its subjects; it aims at the kind of clear-eyed compassion that Bharata associates with the tragic mode.

## 5.3 Law, Conscience, and Moral Inquiry

Mishra's legal career is not incidental to his literary project; it is constitutive of it. As a magistrate, he daily confronts the gap between the law as a formal system and justice as a moral aspiration—the gap that classical jurisprudence has long theorised as the difference between lex (positive law) and ius (natural justice or equity).

Nyaay Kee Guhaar (Plea for Justice) directly thematises this tension. The title—a plea, a cry, a supplication for justice—suggests a protagonist or community for whom legal redress is inadequate or inaccessible, who must therefore appeal to some higher tribunal, whether social conscience, divine justice, or literary testimony.

Lajakotar (a term that evokes the bundle of lajja, shame, that constrains social behaviour) also engages the law-conscience dialectic, but through the lens of gender. In Mithilanchal, as elsewhere in South Asia, 'honour' and 'shame' function as informal codes of social regulation that often work against women's

legal rights and personal freedom. Mishra's novel, by placing lajja in the title's very structure, invites examination of how these codes operate and what forms of resistance are available within them.

From the perspective of Alasdair MacIntyre's virtue ethics and its relevance to legal philosophy, Mishra's fiction can be read as an exploration of what it means to act justly in a social world where formal legal institutions are inadequate to the claims of moral life. This is the existential predicament of the conscientious magistrate: he enforces the law but knows that law and justice are not always the same thing.

## 5.4 Memory, Time, and the Autobiographical Impulse

Bhor San Sanjh Dhari (From Dawn to Dusk) and Prasangavash (By Occasion) belong to the autobiographical and memoiristic strain in Mishra's writing. The first title—'from dawn to dusk'—maps a life onto the diurnal rhythm, suggesting that individual existence is a kind of day: born into light, moving through the arc of activity and experience, arriving at the evening of reflection.

A contemporary of Mishra's who reviewed his early work noted that his writing 'resembles a colourful picture of life, punctuated with not only colour, but humour, happiness and sufferings, failures as well success in one's life.' This description captures the generic hybridity of his memoir—the mixture of tones that Mikhail Bakhtin associated with the novel form as such, but which Mishra deploys in a non-fictional mode.

Beeti Gel Samay (Time That Has Passed), one of his novels, engages more directly with the literary representation of memory and temporal loss. The title resonates with the great tradition of temporal elegy in world literature: Proust's à la recherche du temps perdu, Wordsworth's 'spots of time,' the Sanskrit concept of smara (remembrance) as a form of devotional consciousness. In Maithili literary tradition, this temporal dimension is intimately linked to the seasonal songs (barahmasa) that Vidyapati and his successors wrote, marking the cycle of time through the lens of longing and reunion.

## 5.5 Gender and Patriarchy in Mithila

Mithila is a region deeply structured by Brahminical patriarchy, with an elaborate system of caste endogamy, dowry (which has been a source of considerable violence), and the panjee system—the genealogical records maintained by panji brokers—that has historically regulated marriage and social mobility. Women in this system have occupied positions of

simultaneously central symbolic importance (as the goddesses Durga, Sita, and the mythological heroines of Mithila are celebrated) and structural subordination.

Mishra's fiction engages this contradiction in multiple registers. Fasaad documents the exploitation of women as a social reality. Namastasyai (Salutation to Her) adopts a posture of veneration towards the feminine. Naachi Rahal Chhali Vasudha (The Earth Danced) celebrates female vitality through the figuration of the earth as woman. Lajakotar interrogates the shame codes that confine women.

Using Sandra Gilbert and Susan Gubar's framework, we might ask whether Mishra's female characters suffer from the 'madwoman in the attic' syndrome: are they confined, silenced, and then expressed through authorial ventriloquism? Or does Mishra's writing develop strategies for articulating female subjectivity that go beyond sympathetic representation? The evidence of the works available suggests that this is a tension Mishra is aware of, even if it is not always fully resolved in his writing.

Jayatu Jaanakee (May Janaki Triumph)—the title invoking Sita, the paradigmatic figure of Maithili female identity, who was born in Mithila—is perhaps the most direct engagement with this question. Sita's story is one of radical injustice: she is abducted, rescued, tested, and ultimately abandoned—a narrative of female victimhood redeemed by exemplary moral endurance. Mishra's 'may Janaki triumph' reads as an invocation and a prayer, an assertion that the structural injustice that Sita embodies must be overcome.

## 6. Narrative Technique and Craft

Despite the limited availability of translated or critically analysed texts, some conclusions about Mishra's narrative technique can be drawn from the evidence of titles, descriptions, and genre classifications.

His novels tend towards the realist tradition, engaging closely with social and cultural specificity. The Maithili realist novel, in the tradition of Harimohan Jha and Prabhas Kumar Chaudhary, combines social observation with psychological portraiture and a satirical or compassionate critical intelligence. Mishra works within this tradition while also extending it towards a more contemporary engagement with themes of displacement, bureaucratic modernity, and the crisis of cultural identity in a globalised world.

The memoir (Bhor San Sanjh Dhari) and the essay collection (Vividha Prasanga, Samaadhaan) reveal a prose stylist of considerable flexibility, capable of moving between analytical precision—the legacy of legal training—and lyrical evocation—the legacy of Maithili literary tradition. The reviewer's note that his writing offers 'a natural way of presentation of sequence of events' suggests a prose of apparent simplicity that actually requires considerable craft to achieve.

The presence of The Ganges Whispers as an English-language novel in his corpus indicates a bilingual literary consciousness, one that seeks audiences beyond the Maithili-reading community while maintaining its roots in the Gangetic plain and its cultural traditions. This bilingualism is not unusual among Indian vernacular writers—Nagarjun wrote in both Maithili and Hindi—but it raises interesting questions about translation, code-switching, and the ways in which different languages afford different kinds of literary expression.

## 7. Language and the Maithili Idiom

Maithili is a language of considerable phonological and lexical richness, related to but distinct from Hindi, Bengali, and other eastern Indo-Aryan languages. Its literary vocabulary encompasses Sanskrit-derived tatsama words, Prakrit and Apabhramsha forms preserved from medieval literature, and a rich oral folk tradition. Writers like Vidyapati deployed a lush, sensory vocabulary for the expression of bhakti and shringara; writers like Harimohan Jha developed a satirical prose idiom that mocked the pretensions of the upper-caste intelligentsia through their own linguistic register.

Mishra's relationship to this linguistic inheritance is complex. As a writer who also works in an English-language and legally-inflected professional domain, he brings to Maithili prose a certain precision and directness that coexists with the more lyrical and allusive possibilities of the language. His choice to write primarily in Maithili is an act of linguistic loyalty that has political as well as aesthetic dimensions: it asserts the adequacy of Maithili as a medium for serious contemporary fiction at a historical moment when the language's survival as a literary medium cannot be taken for granted.

The Videha platform, which publishes Mishra's works alongside texts in Tirhuta (the traditional script of Maithili), Devanagari, and Braille, is itself a statement about linguistic pluralism and the importance of maintaining the full range of a language's expressive resources.

## 8. Comparative Literary Perspectives

Reading Mishra comparatively enriches understanding of his achievement and his limitations. Within the Maithili tradition, the closest analogue to his project is perhaps Prabhas Kumar Chaudhary, whose collection Prabhasak Katha won the Sahitya Akademi Award in 1990 and who, like Mishra, combined acute social observation with narrative compassion. The difference is one of generation and context: Chaudhary's work emerged in the social tumult of post-Emergency Bihar; Mishra's in the globalised, digitally-mediated world of contemporary India.

Across Indian literatures, Mishra's work resonates with the social realism of Premchand (Hindi-Urdu), whose Godan and short stories document the exploitation of peasants and women with comparable moral urgency. Like Premchand, Mishra writes from a position of social privilege about those who lack it—a position that generates both the empathy that enables such writing and the structural limitations of such empathy.

Internationally, the closest comparisons are with writers who combine legal or juridical experience with fiction: John Grisham in the thriller tradition (though Mishra's register is more literary), Bernhard Schlink (The Reader), or—more aptly in terms of the moral seriousness and cultural rootedness—Naguib Mahfouz, the Egyptian Nobel laureate who documented Cairo's social transformations with similar compassion and structural integrity. Like Mahfouz, Mishra is a writer of a marginalised cultural tradition who brings to that tradition the tools and perspectives of modernity without abandoning its essential character.

The Ganges Whispers, Mishra's English-language novel, invites comparison with the tradition of Indian writing in English—Amitav Ghosh, Vikram Seth, Arundhati Roy—though Mishra's project is less metropolitan and more consciously embedded in regional culture. Where Roy's The God of Small Things draws on Kerala's cultural specificities for an internationally-oriented literary project, Mishra's English novel appears to be a translation across linguistic boundaries of a sensibility formed in Maithili.

## 9. Conclusion

Rabindra Narayan Mishra is a significant figure in contemporary Maithili literature: a prolific and formally versatile author whose work engages seriously with the great themes of identity, justice, memory, and cultural survival. His position as a practicing magistrate gives his literary engagement with questions of law and conscience a particular authenticity and urgency, while his decades-long commitment to writing in Maithili constitutes a sustained act of cultural and linguistic loyalty.

Analysed through Indian aesthetic frameworks—rasa theory, dhvani, vakrokti, auchitya—his works reveal a writer attuned to the deep emotional and spiritual resources of the Maithili literary tradition, deploying them in service of a contemporary social and moral vision. Analysed through Western frameworks —postcolonial theory, narratology, feminist criticism, cultural materialism— his works emerge as sophisticated engagements with the global discourses of subaltern identity, diasporic belonging, and the politics of minor literatures.

The archiving of his works on Videha—the pioneering Maithili digital literary platform—ensures that they are accessible to a global readership and that they contribute to the larger project of documenting and sustaining a literary tradition of remarkable antiquity and contemporary vitality. This , necessarily preliminary given the limited availability of translated texts and formal critical studies in English, aims to provide a foundation for more sustained scholarly attention to this important body of work.

Future directions include: detailed close readings of individual novels with reference to original Maithili texts; interviews with the author about his creative method and thematic preoccupations; a study of his reception within the Maithili literary community; and translation of key works to enable access by non-Maithili-reading scholars. Such would contribute not only to our understanding of Rabindra Narayan Mishra's individual achievement but to the broader field of Indian literary studies and the global study of minor or regional literatures.

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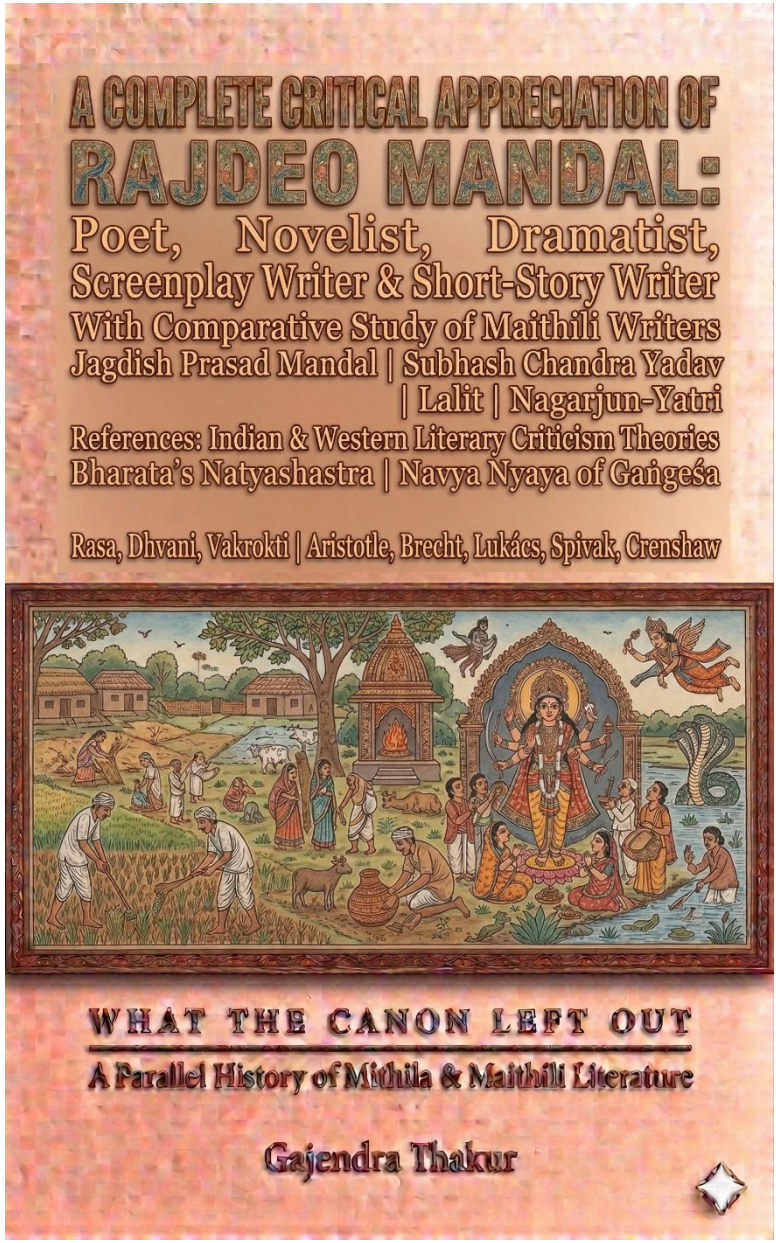
**LESSON 060 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**



# A COMPLETE CRITICAL APPRECIATION OF

# RAJDEO MANDAL

*Poet, Novelist, Dramatist, Screenplay Writer & Short-Story Writer*

With Comparative Study of Maithili Writers

Jagdish Prasad Mandal | Subhash Chandra Yadav | Lalit | Nagarjun-Yatri

References: Indian & Western Literary Criticism Theories

Bharata's Natyashastra | Navya Nyaya of Gaṅgeśa

Rasa, Dhvani, Vakrokti | Aristotle, Brecht, Lukács, Spivak, Crenshaw

## Preface

Rajdeo Mandal (born 15 March 1960, Musaharniyan, Ratanahara, Nirmali, Madhubani, Bihar) is one of the most significant literary voices in contemporary Maithili literature, and unquestionably the most important writer to emerge from the Dhanuk caste community in the language's long history. A poet, novelist, short-story writer, dramatist, and screenplay author whose work spans over three decades, he represents the fullest literary expression of the Videha Maithili Parallel Literature Movement — the movement that has sought to recover, validate, and give artistic form to the lived experience of Mithila's non-Brahminical, subaltern communities.

The present critical appreciation draws on ten texts archived in the Videha Digital Library (www.videha.co.in/pothi.htm): the poetry collection Ambara (2010); the novel Hamar Tol; the screenplay Jal Bhanwar (2019); the one-act play Laj (2015); the short screenplay Panchaiti (2013); the seed-story collection Trivenik Rang (2014); the screenplay Jaal; the novel Waapsi (2018); and the critical study Rajdeo Mandal: Maithili Writer (by Gajendra Thakur, Videha). Together these constitute a representative cross-section of one of the

most socially engaged, linguistically vibrant, and formally versatile bodies of work in post-independence Maithili literature.

The critical apparatus deployed in this appreciation is deliberately pluralist, drawing on: Bharata's Natyashastra and its subsequent elaboration by Abhinavagupta; the Navya Nyaya epistemological tradition of Gangesa Upadhyaya; the Indian aesthetic theories of Anandavardhana (Dhvani), Kuntaka (Vakrokti), and Dandin (Alankara); and Western theories including Aristotle's Poetics, Georg Lukács's theory of realism, Bertolt Brecht's Epic Theatre, Mikhail Bakhtin's dialogism, Walter Benjamin's storytelling theory, Gayatri Spivak's postcolonial criticism, and Kimberlé Crenshaw's intersectionality.

Chapter I: The World of Rajdeo Mandal — Biography, Community, and Context

## 1.1 Biographical Profile

Rajdeo Mandal was born on 15 March 1960 to Sonelal Mandal (Sonai Mandal) and Fulwati Devi in the village of Musaharniyan, Post-Ratanahara, via Nirmali, District Madhubani, Bihar — the heart of the Maithili-speaking belt of North Bihar. His wife is Chandraprabha Devi, and he has three sons (Nishant Mandal, Krishnakant Mandal, Viprakant Mandal) and a daughter (Rashmi Kumari). His natal home (matrka) is Belha, Fulparas, Madhubani. He holds advanced degrees: M.A. in Maithili, M.A. in Hindi, and LL.B. His email rajdeokavi@gmail.com and his publications through Shruti Prakashan, New Delhi (headed by Gajendra Thakur), together indicate both his literary seriousness and his institutional connection to the Videha parallel literary movement.

Mandal belongs to the Dhanuk community — a cultivator-artisan caste classified as Other Backward Classes (OBC) in Bihar's social hierarchy. The Dhanuk jati occupies a middle position in the hierarchical caste structure of Mithila — neither the extreme social exclusion of Dalit communities nor the institutional privilege of the Brahmin-Kayastha elite. The specific socio-cultural situation of the Dhanuk community — their agricultural and artisan traditions, their folk cultural life, their relationship to both upper-caste patronage and lower-caste solidarity — constitutes the social world from which Mandal writes and which his fiction most directly represents.

## 1.2 The Videha Parallel Literature Movement: Context and Ideology

The Videha eJournal (www.videha.co.in, ISSN 2229-547X, since 2008, ed. Gajendra Thakur) has been the institutional home of Rajdeo Mandal's literary career. The India Seminar profile of Videha (Mithilesh Kumar Jha, 2021) explicitly identifies Mandal as one of 'the most notable' writers given a platform by Videha alongside Jagadish Prasad Mandal, Umesh Paswan, Munnaji, and Ashish Anchinhar. This recognition situates Rajdeo Mandal as a pillar of the parallel literature tradition — the tradition that Gajendra Thakur defines as arising from 'the missing portions, the ignored and non-represented aspects of society' in mainstream (Brahmin-dominant) Maithili literary production.

T.K. Oommen's sociological observation — that 'the Maithili region is found to be economically and culturally dominated by Brahmins' — frames the political context of Mandal's parallel literary project. Against this background of Brahmin cultural hegemony, his emergence as the first Dhanuk-caste novelist in Maithili, his sustained output across multiple genres, and his consistent thematic focus on OBC community life constitute a literary-political act of cultural counter-assertion.

## 1.3 Gangesa Upadhyaya and the Mithila Epistemological Tradition

The Navya Nyaya school of Gangesa Upadhyaya (Mithila, c. 14th century) — whose Tattvacintamani provides the systematic analysis of the four pramanas (pratyaksha, anumana, upamana, shabda) — is not merely an abstract philosophical framework but a lived intellectual heritage of Mithila. Crucially, as the Rajdeo Mandal: Maithili Writer document reveals, Gangesa's own family background was socially marginalised: the text quotes Dinesh Chandra Bhattacharya's observation (sourced from Videha's Panji Prabandh research) that 'Gangesha's family is completely ignored' in the official Brahminical genealogical record (Panji) of Mithila, and that Gangesa himself married a woman of artisan background (Charmkarini).

This biographical detail is not incidental — it is central to the critical framework of this appreciation. The founder of Mithila's greatest philosophical tradition was himself socially marginalised by the Brahmin caste apparatus. Rajdeo Mandal, writing from within a similarly marginalised community, enacts a kind of literary Navya Nyaya: he subjects the received 'cognitions'

(jnana) of mainstream Maithili culture — its assumptions about who matters, whose stories deserve telling, whose language constitutes proper literary Maithili — to rigorous critical scrutiny, identifying these as false cognitions (bhrama) and replacing them with prama (valid cognition) grounded in the pratyaksha of first-hand community experience.

# Chapter II: The Works — A Systematic Survey and Analysis

## 2.1 Ambara (The Sky/Canopy) — Poetry Collection, 2010

Ambara (ISBN 978-93-80538-30-3, Shruti Prakashan, 2010; 104 pages) is Rajdeo Mandal's debut poetry collection and, according to Gajendra Thakur's preface, 'the best collection of this genre in the first decade of the 21st Century' in Maithili. The preface — a substantial critical essay by Thakur published within the collection — establishes the critical framework for reading Mandal's poetry: it is poetry that arises from existential social necessity rather than aesthetic fashion or careerist calculation.

The collection's table of contents reveals its thematic range: poems titled 'Aah' (Sighing/Lament), 'Gyanak Jhanda' (Flag of Knowledge), 'Jhapal Astitva' (Veiled Existence), 'Rahab Ahanksang' (Will Remain With You), 'Nadik Machh' (Fish of the River), 'Bat-Batahi' (Traveller), 'Seema Parak Jhula' (Swing at the Boundary), 'Chirrik Jati' (Species of the Bird), 'Badhik' (Flood) and many more. This thematic range — from personal lament to existential questioning, from nature imagery to social critique — demonstrates the full emotional and intellectual spectrum of Mandal's poetic vision.

The poem quoted by Gajendra Thakur in Rajdeo Mandal: Maithili Writer as an exemplar of Mandal's poetic excellence deserves full attention:

*'Tap-tap chubait khunaka bun se / Dharati bha rahal snat / Puchhi rahal achhi chirai / Apna man se i baat / Aaba bala i kari aa bhari raat / Ki nahi bachat hamar jati...?'*

(From the percolating drops of blood / The earth has become freshly bathed / The bird then asks / From its heart / In the incoming heavy and pitch-dark night / Would our species survive?)

Thakur's commentary is precise: 'then it goes into our blood and the blood starts running fast. The species of the poetics of the poet or the species of

that bird? No nod of partisan critiques or a self-obsessed preface is required for this poem. No cartel or crutches of ideology are required for this creation.' This critical observation — that Mandal's best poetry achieves its effect through intrinsic power rather than ideological scaffolding — is the key to understanding his poetic achievement.

Applied through Anandavardhana's Dhvani theory: the poem's surface level (blood, earth, bird, night) carries layers of dhvani (resonance) that suggest simultaneously: the blood of caste violence; the earth as both the literal ground of agricultural labour and the motherland of Dhanuk community life; the bird as both a literal endangered species and the endangered species of Dhanuk cultural identity; and the dark night as both the coming night and the darkness of social oppression. The vyanjana-artha (suggested meaning) operates at multiple levels simultaneously, each layer reinforcing the others to produce an experience of social-existential pathos that transcends any single reading.

From Kuntaka's Vakrokti perspective, the poem's 'oblique expression' operates through the substitution of the bird and the bleeding earth for a direct statement about caste violence — the indirect figuration creates a more powerful effect than direct social commentary would achieve. The vacokti (creative obliqueness) of asking 'would our species survive?' through a bird's self-questioning transforms a potentially didactic social statement into an experience of shared existential vulnerability.

The other English-translated poem from Ambara — 'Rahab Ahank Sang' (Will Remain With You) — reveals a different but equally powerful register:

*'Crying, calling / My throat dried / The lips dried / As if I was thirsty / The corpses all around / Are laughing at me / Nobody is listening to my voice / Where has gone / My society...'*

This poem's register is that of karuna-rasa (compassion/pathos) and vira-rasa (heroic resolution) in dialectical tension: the speaker confronts social isolation (the corpses laughing, the absence of a listening society) yet declares an unwavering commitment to remain — 'I will be with you all only, peacefully.' The Natyashastra's concept of vibhava (excitant), anubhava (consequent), and vyabhichari-bhava (transient emotion) maps directly onto this poem's emotional structure: the vibhava (social abandonment and oppression) produces the anubhava (the drying throat, the failed voice) and the vyabhichari-bhavas (alternating between despair and resolve) that together constitute the dominant rasa of karuna.

## 2.2 Hamar Tol (My Quarter of the Village) — Novel

Hamar Tol is Rajdeo Mandal's landmark novel and the work that most fully establishes his position in Maithili literary history. Gajendra Thakur's extended critical analysis in Rajdeo Mandal: Maithili Writer places it in direct comparison with Nagarjun-Yatri's Paro — the only earlier Maithili novel that attempted a first-hand account of a specific caste community's life from within.

The critical comparison is illuminating: 'Paro of Nagarjun-Yatri did depict first-hand account of the dwindling culture of his Maithil Brahmin caste of contemporary times... The novel Hamar Tol by Rajdeo Mandal is a first-hand account of his Dhanuk caste of Mithila and has been written in the settings of the socio-cultural situation that this caste is peculiarly placed in.' The parallelism is strategic: just as Nagarjun (Baidyanath Mishra 'Yatri', the celebrated Maithili-Hindi poet and Sahitya Akademi Fellow) wrote from within his Brahmin community's experience, Mandal writes from within the Dhanuk community's experience. The difference is that Mandal's community had never before had a novelist who could render its world in literary form.

The novel's ending — described as necessarily tragic because 'the author, being a realistic writer, has been forced to make the ending a tragic one' — marks Mandal as a practitioner of social realism in the tradition that Georg Lukács theorised: the realistic novel does not impose false consolations but traces the contradictions of social life to their actual (often tragic) resolution. The closing image is striking:

*'Everyone left the scene in a hurry. There began a fight between the Crow and the Myna. That fight remained unseen, only the tree saw it. And the tree saw many more things, yet the tree remained silent.'*

Thakur's commentary identifies the significance of this silence: 'The complexity and perplexity of that silence could be refined and presented owing to the first-hand experiences of those unseen things by second-hand accounts.' The tree's silence is the silence of nature as witness to social conflict — a figure that carries enormous resonance in the agrarian world of Mithila, where the natural environment (trees, rivers, fields) is saturated with cultural meaning. The tree sees the fight between Crow and Myna (the internal conflict of competing interests or forces within the subaltern community itself) — but remains silent, unable or unwilling to intervene. This is Mandal's most sophisticated narrative device: the silent witness who knows but cannot speak represents the structural impossibility of articulating the full complexity of subaltern experience within the available social language.

Furthermore, Thakur credits Hamar Tol with a specific literary-historical function: 'The Hamar Tol of Rajdeo Mandal purifies the account of the second-hand account by Lalit in Prithviputra; as a result, the parallel movement of the stream was able to take along the main course of literature and moved it forward and made it relevant.' The contrast with Lalit's Prithviputra — the celebrated earlier Maithili novel by the Brahmin writer Lalitesh Mishra('Lalit') which deals with peasant and rural themes — reveals the key distinction: Lalit wrote about the lower castes from the outside, as a sympathetic but external observer; Mandal writes from within, with the specificity of first-hand knowledge that only insider experience can provide.

Applying the Navya Nyaya distinction between pratyaksha (direct perception/first-hand knowledge) and anumana (inference/second-hand knowledge): Lalit's Prithviputra offers anumana-based knowledge of the subaltern world — the intelligent inference of an outsider who observes and sympathises. Mandal's Hamar Tol offers pratyaksha-based knowledge — the direct perceptual validity of first-hand experience. In Gangesa's epistemological framework, pratyaksha is the most foundational pramana; anumana, however valid, is always derivative. This is why Hamar Tol 'purifies' the account of Prithviputra — it replaces derivative knowledge with foundational knowledge.

## 2.3 Jal Bhanwar (Water Vortex) — Screenplay, 2019

Jal Bhanwar (ISBN 978-93-87675-49-0, 2019; 110 pages) is Rajdeo Mandal's major screenplay — a substantial work that demonstrates his formal range beyond novel and poetry. The title — 'water vortex' or 'whirlpool' — evokes the image of turbulent water that draws objects into its center, a powerful metaphor for the social forces that trap individuals in cycles of poverty, exploitation, and caste oppression.

The screenplay form is significant in itself: Maithili screenplay writing is a rare genre, and Mandal's preface to Jaal notes that he undertook screenplay writing 'seeing the absence of screenplays in Maithili literature.' This act of genre-pioneering — identifying a gap in the literary system and filling it — is characteristic of Mandal's approach to literary production. He is not merely responding to individual creative impulses but actively mapping and developing the generic landscape of Maithili literature.

From Bharata's Natyashastra perspective, the screenplay form engages with what the text calls 'natyadharmi' — the theatrical representation that transforms reality into aesthetic form through the combined means of word,

gesture, costume, music, and spectacle. The screenplay, as a genre that anticipates cinematic realisation, engages with a specifically modern form of natyadharmi that Bharata could not have anticipated but whose fundamental principle — the transformation of lived experience into performable representation — his theory encompasses.

The Natyashastra's concept of 'artha' (purpose/meaning) — that dramatic representation must serve a social and spiritual purpose — is directly relevant to Mandal's screenplay writing. In the foreword to Jaal, he states: 'I have made a small effort, even without being skilled in the subject.' This characteristic modesty is accompanied by a clear awareness of purpose: to contribute to the development of a Maithili screenplay tradition that can serve as the basis for a Maithili cinema industry and cultural presence.

## 2.4 Laj (Shame) — One-Act Play, 2015

Laj (27 pages, dated 14 January 2015) is Rajdeo Mandal's most direct dramatic work — a one-act play that addresses two central social problems in rural Mithila: the dowry system and the exploitation of lower-caste girls by upper-caste landlords. The character list includes Haricharan (a farmer), Dhirba (his son), Kulanand (a rich landlord), Bhogendra (his son), Bisekhi (a labourer), Shyambabu (a teacher); and women: Chanpatiwali (Haricharan's wife) and Sabita (his daughter). This social panorama — spanning the spectrum from landless labourer to landlord — is characteristic of Mandal's dramaturgy.

The preface by Mandal is brief and revealing: 'Close friends wanted me to write a play. To honour their request, I made an attempt at a one-act play. Whether it succeeded or failed, the decision is for society to make.' This deferral to social judgment — not to academic critics or literary establishments but to 'society' (samaj) — reflects Mandal's understanding of literature as a social rather than aesthetic institution.

The opening of Laj — Haricharan asking where his daughter Sabita has gone, his wife reporting that the girl is tending cattle in the fields — immediately establishes the social register: the daughters of poor farming families are engaged in productive agricultural labour while being denied the education that upper-caste families take for granted. The play proceeds through the recognition of this social disparity toward its dramatic confrontation — the moment of 'laj' (shame) that gives the play its title. This shame operates in multiple directions: the shame felt by lower-caste families in the face of upper-caste power; the shame that should be felt by exploitative upper-caste figures

but often is not; and the shame of a social system that has normalised such exploitation.

From the Natyashastra's analysis of the six 'sandhi' (joints/junctures) of dramatic structure — mukha (opening), pratimukha (movement toward complication), garbha (intensification), vimarsha (deliberation), and nirvahana (resolution) — Laj follows a compressed but structurally coherent dramatic architecture. The opening domestic scene (mukha) establishes the social status quo; the entrance of the landlord's son and his interest in Sabita creates the complication (pratimukha); the intensification of the threat to Sabita's dignity (garbha) brings the dramatic conflict to its peak; the community's deliberation about how to respond (vimarsha) leads to the resolution (nirvahana) — which, in Mandal's realist mode, is likely to be partial or ambiguous rather than triumphant.

## 2.5 Panchaiti (Village Panchayat) — Short Screenplay, 2013

Panchaiti (16 pages, 2013; Shruti Prakashan) is a compact but powerful short screenplay addressing inter-caste elopement and the role of the village panchayat in adjudicating social conflict. The character list is clear: Dhanesr, Ramua (Lalita's father), four villagers, Sahdev (Kishan's father), Master Sahib, the Panch Pramukh, three Panchas, a Jamadar, Kishan; and women: Dhanesr's wife, Geeta (his daughter), Kishan's mother.

The dramatic action: Kishan and Geeta (from different castes) are in love and have apparently eloped or been found together. The village panchayat is convened to adjudicate. The crucial dramatic moment arrives when Sahdev tells Kishan to send Geeta home: 'If you want your own good, send her back to her home, or they will make your life miserable.' Kishan responds with a remarkable statement: 'What should I say? We both love each other... We both are adults. I have the right to marry by law.' This assertion of legal rights against caste custom — the appeal to the constitutional right to inter-caste marriage against the authority of the panchayat — is the play's central dramatic action.

Panchaiti engages with what legal scholars call the 'khap panchayat' phenomenon — the self-appointed caste councils that in many parts of North India arrogate to themselves the power to regulate inter-caste and inter-gotra relationships, often with violent consequences. Mandal's dramatisation of this conflict through the medium of a village panchayat scene gives it both legal weight (the appeal to constitutional rights) and local specificity (the recognisable social dynamics of Mithila village governance).

From Aristotle's Poetics, the play employs 'anagnorisis' (recognition/discovery) — the moment when a character or the audience recognises a truth previously hidden. The discovery in Panchaiti is not of individual identity but of social truth: the discovery that caste-based panchayat authority is illegitimate when it conflicts with the constitutional right to marry; and the recognition that two young people in love possess legal rights that even traditional community authority cannot override. This anagnorisis does not resolve the social conflict — the play's realism prevents such easy resolution — but it creates the cognitive space within which the audience can recognise the injustice of the caste system's claim to regulate love.

## 2.6 Trivenik Rang (Colours of the Triveni) — Seed-Story Collection, 2014

Trivenik Rang (18 pages, 2014; © Rajdeo 2014) is a collection of 'vihani katha' (seed stories) — a genre specific to the Videha parallel tradition that represents the shortest possible narrative form, typically a few hundred words, in which a complete social situation or moral dilemma is compressed into its essential elements. The title — 'Colours of the Triveni' (the confluence point of three rivers, traditionally the sacred confluence of Ganga, Yamuna, and Saraswati) — suggests a collection that brings together multiple narrative strands, each distinct in colour (tone, theme, mood) but flowing toward a common confluence.

The seed story or vihani katha represents Maithili's contribution to the world tradition of the very short story — akin to the Japanese haiku in prose form, or the 'flash fiction' of contemporary English literature. Walter Benjamin's famous meditation on storytelling — 'The Storyteller' (1936) — is relevant here: Benjamin contrasts the dying oral tradition of storytelling (rooted in experience and community) with the rise of the novel (rooted in isolation and print culture). The vihani katha represents precisely the kind of story that Benjamin sees as recovering the experiential richness of the oral tradition within a literary form — stories that carry 'counsel' for the listener/reader, rooted in the specific texture of lived experience.

## 2.7 Jaal (The Net) — Screenplay

Jaal (20 pages) is Rajdeo Mandal's screenplay exploring the social 'net' — the web of obligations, exploitations, and structural constraints — in which the characters of rural Mithila find themselves trapped. The title directly echoes the poem in Hamar Tol's preface: 'Machhi jal me lok fansal / Machh puchhai

achhi — ki yau bhai? / Lok kahai — kichhu kahal nai jay. / Hamare hath se jal banal / Hamrepar achhi ab tanel' (People are trapped in the fish net / The fish asks — what is it, brother? / The person says — nothing can be said / The net was made by our own hands / Now it is tightened on us ourselves).

This extraordinarily powerful metaphor — the net made by one's own hands that now traps its maker — encapsulates the Marxist concept of 'alienation' in Maithili poetic terms, without any need for imported theoretical vocabulary. The net-makers (the peasant-artisan communities of Mithila who have sustained the social and economic fabric of the region) find themselves trapped by the very social structures they have created and maintained through their labour. Jaal dramatises this entrapment through its narrative of rural characters caught in cycles of poverty, exploitation, and social constraint.

The screenplay's specific opening scene — Vikram waking up to bring milk to the city, his bicycle journey through the village — captures the daily temporal rhythm of subaltern rural life with remarkable specificity. The detail of the bicycle, the urgency of the milk delivery, the interactions with Raghua and Barsa, the cut-scenes (kat-tu, 'cut to') that structure the cinematic time — all demonstrate Mandal's sophisticated grasp of screenplay form and his ability to render the texture of rural Mithila life in cinematic terms.

## 2.8 Waapsi (Return) — Novel/Text, 2018

Waapsi (ISBN 978-93-88421-88-1, 2018; 38 pages; Pallavi Prakashan, New Delhi) represents Mandal's return to extended prose fiction. The title — 'Return' — is thematically rich: it suggests the return of a character to their home or community, the return of a repressed memory or truth, or the return of justice in a world of social wrongs. Published by a different publisher (Pallavi Prakashan) from his usual Shruti Prakashan, Waapsi demonstrates his expanding reach beyond the Videha institutional network.

The dedication in Waapsi — 'Sahityasaneh rakhinhar / Suphijan ke samar samip' (For those who maintain love of literature / Presented to the near community of good people) — reveals the community orientation of Mandal's literary self-understanding. He does not dedicate to an individual or to an abstraction but to the community of literary lovers — the implied reading public of his work.

# Chapter III: The Short Stories — Five Key Texts

## 3.1 Rusal Bauwa (An Angry Boy)

Rusal Bauwa — described as reminiscent of Premchand's Idgah to its first critic, Narayanji — is Mandal's most celebrated short story. Written for the '82nd Sagar Raati Deep Jaray' — the night-long quarterly short story recitation programme held in villages of Mithila — it demonstrates the social institution within which his early fiction was produced: a community oral performance context, not a literary journal or publishing house.

The Premchand comparison is instructive and needs careful analysis. Premchand's Idgah depicts the poignant situation of a poor Muslim boy at a fair who spends all his money buying a pair of tongs for his grandmother rather than toys for himself — an act of child altruism that illuminates the economics of poverty and the moral economy of love. Rusal Bauwa inverts this emotional register: Fekan's son is angry — he wants new clothes like Dhirendra Babu's son Amit before he will attend the Durga Puja fair. But the crucial detail is that 'Fekan's son is much ahead of Amit, son of Dhirendra Babu in every respect, be it study or sports' despite Fekan being poor and Dhirendra Babu being rich. The story thus dramatises not poverty's self-abnegation (as in Idgah) but poverty's legitimate anger — the refusal to accept the humiliation of visible economic inequality when the poor child knows his own capabilities exceed those of the rich.

This shift from Premchand's accommodating altruism to Mandal's assertive anger is politically significant. Premchand's child-hero exemplifies the moral economy of sacrifice and love across class differences; Mandal's child-hero refuses to accept the visible markers of inequality as natural or inevitable. This is the literature of subaltern assertion rather than subaltern accommodation — a distinction that maps directly onto the difference between the mainstream Maithili tradition's accommodative social ethics and the parallel tradition's assertive social consciousness.

## 3.2 Bechuak Suiter (A Sweater for Bechua)

Bechuak Suiter deals with bonded labour, child labour, poverty, and police corruption — a cluster of social pathologies that the mainstream Maithili literary tradition had largely ignored. The protagonist Bechua is a boy working at a tea-stall — a child labourer whose existence represents the failure of the

state to protect children's rights. The sweater of the title is a symbol of warmth, care, and material provision — the basic necessities that poverty denies.

The story's engagement with police corruption places it in dialogue with a long tradition of subaltern literature that documents the structural corruption of state institutions as experienced from below. The police, in Mandal's story, are not protectors of the vulnerable but participants in the system of exploitation. This is the pratyaksha (direct perceptual experience) of the subaltern community rendered in literary form — the day-to-day reality of living at the intersection of poverty and official malfeasance.

## 3.3 Electionak Bhoot (The Ghost of Election)

Electionak Bhoot is described as a 'wonderful treat' in which the protagonist depicts a sequence of events that turns out to be happening in his dream — a narrative device of remarkable sophistication. The 'ghost of election' — the haunting of public life by electoral politics, with its vote-buying, its caste mobilisation, its corruption and violence — is figured as a dream or nightmare that the protagonist both experiences and (through the dream-frame) observes with critical detachment.

This narrative device engages with what Brecht called the 'alienation effect' — the device that creates critical distance from the immediate material while maintaining emotional engagement with it. By framing the electoral corruption as a dream, Mandal enables both the emotional intensity of witnessing it and the cognitive distance of knowing it is a dream — precisely the Brechtian combination of feeling and understanding that effective political theatre (and fiction) requires.

## 3.4 Rakhbar (The Village Guard)

Rakhbar — the story of Musba, the guard — introduces gender dynamics in a complex way. Musba, who is 'a terror outside' is 'tamed inside his house' by his daughter-in-law. The story extends to Sumna, who attacks Musba when he behaves lecherously with her. This is one of Mandal's most direct treatments of gender and sexual violence within the subaltern community itself — acknowledging that patriarchal violence is not exclusively an upper-caste phenomenon but operates within OBC communities as well.

Gajendra Thakur's critical observation is precise: 'In all the stories you will find the use of words and contexts which is absent in mainstream literature. The vibrant life, the story of gloom, and cultural paraphernalia even amid

poverty were never heard of before the parallel tradition storytellers came to the scene.' This observation identifies the specific literary contribution of Mandal and the parallel tradition: not merely new themes but new vocabulary, new narrative contexts, new sensory and cultural details that the mainstream Brahmin literary tradition had never accessed because it had never lived that life.

# Chapter IV: Critical Frameworks — Indian and Western Theories

## 4.1 Bharata's Natyashastra and the Drama of Social Life

Bharata's Natyashastra (c. 200 BCE-200 CE) — the foundational text of Indian dramaturgy — provides a critical framework whose application to Mandal's drama and screenplay reveals both the continuity and the transformation of Indian theatrical tradition in his work. Bharata's concept of the four abhinayas (modes of representation) — angika (bodily), vachika (verbal), aharya (costumed/visual), and sattvika (emotional/psychophysical) — applies to Mandal's screenplays and plays with specific force. The gamaya (village) Maithili of his dialogue is a specifically calibrated vachika abhinaya — it performs social identity through linguistic register, marking characters as belonging to specific caste-community speech communities.

Bharata's dasarupaka (ten dramatic forms) are relevant to classifying Mandal's dramatic output. His one-act play Laj most closely resembles the vyayoga (action-based short drama) — a compact form dealing with conflict and its immediate social resolution. His screenplay Panchaiti resembles the prahasana (comedic drama revealing social contradictions) in its treatment of the panchayat as both a legitimate and a problematic social institution. His longer screenplays (Jal Bhanwar, Jaal, Waapsi) engage with the natika form — a shorter nataka (heroic drama) dealing with realistic social themes rather than mythological or historical subjects.

The Natyashastra's concept of rasa-siddhi (theatrical success in emotional impact) is achieved in Mandal's work through the specific mechanism of laukika (worldly/experiential) recognition. His village audiences recognise the specific social situations — the panchayat, the electoral corruption, the landlord's exploitation, the labourer's poverty — from their own lived experience. This recognition produces the sadharani-karana

(universalisation) that Abhinavagupta identifies as the basis of aesthetic experience: the transformation of individual experience into shared aesthetic understanding.

## 4.2 Navya Nyaya and the Epistemology of Subaltern Literature

Gangesa Upadhyaya's Navya Nyaya provides the most precise analytical framework for understanding what Rajdeo Mandal's literature does and why it matters. The system's central project — the rigorous analysis of prama (valid cognition) and the identification and correction of bhrama (false cognition) — maps directly onto the parallel literature movement's critique of mainstream Maithili literary culture.

The mainstream Maithili literary tradition produces a systematic bhrama: it presents Brahmin-Kayastha social experience as the universal experience of Mithila, upper-caste literary aesthetics as the universal aesthetics of Maithili, and the exclusion of lower-caste communities from literary representation as the natural order of things. This is bhrama in Gangesa's precise technical sense: a cognition that presents a false universal ('this is Maithili literature') by illegitimately applying a specific predicate (the Brahmin literary tradition) to a universal subject (Maithili literature as a whole).

Mandal's parallel literature corrects this bhrama through the pratyaksha-pramana of first-hand community experience. His novels, stories, and plays do not argue against upper-caste cultural dominance in the abstract — they simply present the Dhanuk community's world in all its specificity and richness, demonstrating through the pratyaksha of literary representation that this world exists, that it is real, that it has its own vocabulary, its own social logic, its own beauty and suffering. This is the literary equivalent of Gangesa's epistemological project: replacing false cognition with valid cognition through rigorous attention to the actual object of knowledge.

The Navya Nyaya concept of avacchedakatva (delimitation/qualification) is particularly relevant to Mandal's novelistic method. His novels precisely delimit their social domain — they are about the Dhanuk community's specific social situation, not about 'Mithila society' in the abstract. This precision of social delimitation is the literary equivalent of Gangesa's insistence on precise definition: the avoidance of false universals through careful specification of the actual object of cognitive attention.

## 4.3 Rasa Theory and the Aesthetics of Subaltern Experience

The rasa theory of Bharatamuni and Abhinavagupta provides the classical Indian framework for understanding the emotional register of Mandal's work. The dominant rasas across his oeuvre are karuna (compassion/pathos) — the aesthetic experience of suffering and loss; vira (heroic resolution) — the aesthetic experience of moral courage in the face of oppression; and raudra (righteous anger) — the aesthetic experience of fury at injustice. These three rasas form a dialectical complex: the pathos of subaltern suffering produces the anger that motivates the heroic resolve to resist and articulate.

Abhinavagupta's concept of brahmananda-sahodarananda (the aesthetic bliss that is 'sister to' the bliss of Brahman consciousness) — the idea that aesthetic experience produces a state of expanded consciousness that transcends the individual ego — has a specific application to Mandal's work. When the reader of Hamar Tol experiences the karuna of the Dhanuk community's suffering, this aesthetic experience produces a form of social consciousness-expansion: the reader (including the non-Dhanuk reader) is momentarily brought within the experiential world of a community whose existence and suffering were previously invisible. This is the social-political function of aesthetic experience — the Abhinavagupta-derived theory explains why representation matters, why giving literary form to subaltern experience has social consequences beyond the literary domain.

## 4.4 Georg Lukács and Social Realism

Georg Lukács's theory of social realism — developed in The Historical Novel (1937), Studies in European Realism (1950), and other works — provides the most directly applicable Western framework for understanding Mandal's novelistic method. For Lukács, the great realist novel is distinguished by its capacity to represent the 'totality' of social life through the specific stories of individual characters — the concrete particular that illuminates the general social structure.

Hamar Tol exemplifies what Lukács calls 'typicality' — the representation of characters who, in their specific individuality, embody the social-historical forces of their time and place. The Dhanuk characters of Hamar Tol are not sociological abstractions or representatives of a thesis; they are fully realised individuals whose specific choices, relationships, and fates illuminate the structural conditions of Dhanuk community life in contemporary Mithila. This is the literary achievement that Gajendra Thakur identifies when

he says Hamar Tol 'has secured its position in the literary history of Maithili literature': it achieves the kind of realist totality that Lukács identifies as the mark of significant fiction.

The tragic ending of Hamar Tol is also Lukácsian in its rationale: the great realist novel does not impose a false resolution but traces the contradictions of social life to their actual outcome. The social reality of Dhanuk community life in Mithila does not offer easy resolutions — the structural forces of caste oppression, economic marginalisation, and political corruption are not overcome by individual heroism or moral virtue. The tragic ending is not pessimistic but honest: it reflects the actual weight of social contradiction as experienced from within the community.

## 4.5 Bakhtin's Dialogism and the Polyphony of Subaltern Voices

Mikhail Bakhtin's theory of novelistic dialogism — the idea that the novel is inherently a multi-voiced form in which different social languages, ideologies, and perspectives are brought into productive tension — illuminates an important dimension of Mandal's fiction. His novels and plays are marked by what Bakhtin calls 'heteroglossia' (raznorechie) — the multiplicity of social languages coexisting within a single text.

In Hamar Tol and his plays, multiple social registers coexist: the gamaya Maithili of Dhanuk community members, the somewhat more formal Maithili of masters and teachers, the dialect features associated with different caste communities, and the occasional Hindi/English intrusions of bureaucratic and official language. This linguistic heteroglossia is not merely descriptive detail but a form of social analysis: the coexistence of these registers within the text makes audible the social hierarchy that structures language use in Mithila, and allows the lower-register voices (the Dhanuk community's speech) to assert their presence and dignity within the literary space.

## 4.6 Gayatri Spivak and the Speaking Subaltern

Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's canonical question — 'Can the subaltern speak?' — receives a specific literary answer in Rajdeo Mandal's work. Spivak's argument is that the subaltern cannot speak 'in the full sense' within the institutional structures of representation that exist — that every act of speaking within established institutional channels requires the subaltern to translate their experience into the language and categories of the dominant culture, losing something essential in the process.

The Videha parallel literature movement — and Rajdeo Mandal within it — represents a partial but significant attempt to create institutional structures in which the subaltern can speak more fully. The digital archive of Videha, the publication network of Shruti Prakashan, the community performance traditions of the vihani katha and the Sagar Raati Deep Jaray programme, and the grassroots readership of parallel Maithili literature all constitute alternative institutional channels through which the subaltern can speak — not in perfect freedom from dominant cultural constraints, but with more fidelity to their own experience than the mainstream literary institutions would allow.

Mandal's choice to write in gamaya Maithili rather than the standardised literary Maithili of the Brahmin-Kayastha tradition is the linguistic enactment of the subaltern's speaking: it insists that the Dhanuk community's speech is a legitimate literary language, that their stories can be told in their own words, that their experience does not need to be translated into upper-caste linguistic categories to be literarily valid.

## 4.7 Intersectionality and the Complexity of Oppression

Kimberlé Crenshaw's theory of intersectionality — the idea that different forms of social oppression (race, class, gender, caste) operate simultaneously and compound each other — provides the most precise analytical framework for understanding the social world depicted in Mandal's work. His characters do not experience oppression as a single, uniform force but as the intersection of multiple, mutually reinforcing systems: caste discrimination, class exploitation, gender oppression, and the structural violence of state institutions.

The woman characters in Mandal's drama — Geeta in Panchaiti, Sabita in Laj, Sumna in Rakhbar — experience this intersectional oppression most vividly. Geeta faces both caste discrimination (her right to love across caste boundaries is denied by the panchayat) and gender discrimination (her choices are overridden by male family members and community elders). Sabita faces class vulnerability (as the daughter of a poor farmer) and gender vulnerability (as a girl exposed to landlord predation). Sumna faces the intersection of gender violence and poverty that makes her particularly vulnerable to Musba's lechery. The intersectional complexity of these women's situations is one of the most important contributions of Mandal's literature to contemporary Maithili fiction.

### 4.8 Walter Benjamin and the Art of Storytelling

Walter Benjamin's meditation on 'The Storyteller' (1936) — his analysis of the dying art of oral storytelling and the loss of communicable experience in modernity — provides a productive framework for understanding the cultural function of Mandal's vihani katha (seed stories). Benjamin argues that the great storyteller draws on a 'community of listeners' who share a common experience and for whom the story carries 'counsel' — practical wisdom distilled from lived experience and transmitted across generations.

The institutional context of Mandal's early storytelling — the Sagar Raati Deep Jaray programme, where stories are read aloud and immediately critiqued by community members in an all-night gathering — is precisely the kind of storytelling community that Benjamin describes as the origin and natural habitat of the story form. The vihani katha, in this context, is not a literary experiment but a continuation and formal refinement of the oral storytelling tradition, given written form without losing its communal, experiential character.

## Chapter V: Comparative Study — Rajdeo Mandal and Other Maithili Writers

### 5.1 Rajdeo Mandal and Jagdish Prasad Mandal

The most obvious and most significant comparison is with Jagdish Prasad Mandal — the other major figure of the Videha parallel tradition and, alongside Rajdeo Mandal, one of the two most important subaltern voices in contemporary Maithili literature. Both writers are OBC, both work within the Videha movement, both have received the Videha Samman. Jagdish Prasad Mandal (Yadav community) received the Tagore Sahitya Samman for his short story collection Gamak Jinaagi — a recognition that the parallel tradition earned before any of its writers received institutional establishment recognition.

The key difference between the two Mandals is one of community specificity and generic range. Jagdish Prasad Mandal's work is rooted in the Yadav community's relationship to Mithila's rural society and folk culture — he is more deeply embedded in the folk tradition (proverbs, community gatherings, agricultural cycles) and his prose has the rhythmic quality of oral

literature. Rajdeo Mandal's work engages more directly with the formal literary genres (novel, screenplay, one-act play, poetry collection) and with contemporary social-political themes (electoral corruption, legal rights, bonded labour, inter-caste love). The two together constitute the full breadth of the parallel tradition's literary achievement.

## 5.2 Rajdeo Mandal and Nagarjun-Yatri

The comparison with Nagarjun (Baidyanath Mishra 'Yatri', 1911-1998) — the celebrated Maithili-Hindi poet and Sahitya Akademi Fellow — is established within the Rajdeo Mandal: Maithili Writer document itself, through the comparison of Hamar Tol with Paro. Nagarjun's significance is enormous: he was the first major Maithili writer to write from within his Brahmin community's lived experience (Paro), the first to engage seriously with Marxist politics in Maithili poetry, and the first to achieve national recognition across both Maithili and Hindi literary spheres.

The difference is one of community position and critical distance. Nagarjun, despite his Marxist politics and his sympathy with the oppressed, wrote as a Brahmin who chose progressive politics — an intellectual act of solidarity rather than a first-hand account of subaltern experience. Rajdeo Mandal writes from within the OBC community's lived reality — the pratyaksha of insider experience rather than the anumana of sympathetic observation. The Navya Nyaya distinction between these two epistemic positions marks the qualitative difference in their respective literary achievements.

## 5.3 Rajdeo Mandal and Lalit (Lalitesh Mishra)

Lalit's Prithviputra — the celebrated Maithili novel that attempted to represent rural and peasant Mithila from an upper-caste perspective — is explicitly contrasted with Hamar Tol in the critical apparatus of the Videha movement. Thakur's formulation is precise: Hamar Tol 'purifies the account of the second-hand account by Lalit in Prithviputra.' This 'purification' is not a dismissal of Lalit's literary achievement but an identification of its structural limitation: as a Brahmin writing about peasant-caste life, Lalit could offer only anumana (inference/second-hand knowledge), however sympathetically rendered.

The structural difference between Lalit's outsider perspective and Mandal's insider perspective maps onto what postcolonial theory calls the difference between representation 'for' and representation 'by' the subaltern —

the difference between the sympathetic upper-caste writer who speaks for the oppressed (albeit with the best intentions) and the subaltern writer who speaks in their own voice, from within their own community's experience.

## 5.4 Rajdeo Mandal and Subhash Chandra Yadav

Subhash Chandra Yadav is another significant figure of the Videha parallel tradition — a novelist whose works Gulo and Vote demonstrate a sophisticated engagement with contemporary political reality and rural life. The Videha movement has strongly promoted Yadav's work as one of the major achievements of the parallel tradition, and the critical attacks on his work by establishment critics (particularly Kamalananda Jha's dismissal in his 2021 'Maithili Novel' survey) have been strongly defended by Thakur.

Compared with Rajdeo Mandal, Subhash Chandra Yadav demonstrates a more overtly political and contemporary focus — his Vote is explicitly about the electoral process; his Gulo engages with the dynamics of village community and individual aspiration. Mandal's work, by contrast, is more deeply rooted in the specific community world of the Dhanuk jati — the micro-social fabric of a particular caste community's life, rather than the macro-political dynamics of electoral democracy. Together, the two writers cover the full spectrum from community interiority to political exteriority within the parallel tradition.

**Comparative Matrix: Rajdeo Mandal and Maithili Writers**

| Criterion | Rajdeo Mandal | Jagdish Prasad Mandal | Subhash Chandra Yadav | Lalit (Lalitesh Mishra) |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Caste/ Community | Dhanuk (OBC artisan-cultivator) | Mandal (Yadav/OBC) | Yadav (OBC) | Brahmin (Kayastha-adjacent) |
| Primary Genre | Poetry, novel, drama/screenplay, short story | Poetry, novel, short story | Novel, short story | Novel, long fiction |
| Thematic | Dhanuk | Rural OBC | Village | Social |

| | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Core | community life, subaltern dignity, caste oppression, gender, electoral corruption | life, folk ethos, Mithila village society | realism, political satire, social justice | reform, middle-class Mithila, marriage reform |
| Language Register | Gamaya Maithili of OBC communities; oral-folk textures | Robust Maithili of peasant communities; proverbial richness | Standard Maithili with contemporary urban-rural mix | Literary standard Maithili; classical resonances |
| Navya Nyaya Application | Pratyaksha of lived Dhanuk reality; correction of caste-brahmic bhrama | Sabda of folk tradition as pramana; anumana of social structure | Anumana of political contradictions; vakya-pramana | Inference of social change; upamana with classical texts |
| Narrative Mode | Social realism with tragic closure; episodic in drama | Epic realism; cyclical folk narrative | Contemporary realism; political allegory | Satirical realism; comedic social critique |
| Key Works | Hamar Tol (novel), Ambara (poems), Jal Bhanwar, Laj, Panchaiti, Triveni Rang, Jaal, Waapsi | Gamak Jinaagi, Sahasrabadhani, Teen Jeth Egarham Maagh | Gulo, Vote, Mamata | Prithviputra, Lalit-sahitya |
| Parallel | Major; first | Foundational | Significant | Earlier |

| | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Tradition Contribution | Dhanuk-caste novelist in Maithili; Videha Samman recipient | ; Tagore Sahitya Samman, Videha Samman | contributio n to Videha tradition | tradition; later co-opted by mainstrea m |
| Western Parallel | Chinua Achebe, Mulk Raj Anand, Dalit fiction tradition | Gabriel García Márquez, Premchand | Fyodor Dostoevsky (political), Orwell | Anton Chekhov, Jane Austen (social comedy) |

Chapter VI: Rajdeo Mandal — Drama, Screenplay, and the Question of Cinema

## 6.1 The Screenplay as Genre Pioneer

Rajdeo Mandal's contribution to Maithili screenplay writing is a dimension of his literary work that deserves special attention. In his foreword to Jaal, he explicitly notes 'the absence of screenplays in Maithili literature' and frames his attempt as filling this gap — an act of generic pioneering that places him alongside those writers who have sought to develop Maithili as a fully equipped literary language capable of serving all the major genres of modern literary production.

The significance of this generic development extends beyond the purely literary: Maithili cinema has been a largely marginal and underdeveloped phenomenon compared to neighbouring Hindi and Bhojpuri cinema industries. The development of Maithili screenplay writing as a literary genre could potentially serve as the foundation for a more developed Maithili film tradition — one that draws on the richness of Maithili literature and the specificity of Mithila's social and cultural world. In this sense, Mandal's screenplay writing is a literary act with potential cinematic consequences.

## 6.2 Drama and the Social Functions of Theatre

Mandal's dramatic works — Laj (one-act play) and Panchaiti (short screenplay) — engage with a tradition of Indian social drama that extends from the colonial-period reform plays (Vishnudas Bhave, Jyotiraose Phule,

Rabindranath Tagore's early social plays) through the post-independence tradition of committed theatre (Indian People's Theatre Association, Badal Sircar's 'Third Theatre,' Safdar Hashmi's Jana Natya Manch) to the contemporary tradition of subaltern theatre represented by Bechan Thakur's Videha parallel theatre movement.

The connection between Rajdeo Mandal's dramatic writing and Bechan Thakur's theatrical practice is productive: both engage with the same social problems (caste discrimination, dowry, inter-caste love, panchayat justice/injustice), both draw on the gamaya tradition of Mithila village performance, and both are committed to the Videha movement's project of subaltern cultural assertion. The difference is one of primary medium: Thakur's theatre is primarily performative, while Mandal's dramatic writing is primarily literary — designed for reading and publishing as much as for performance.

# Chapter VII: Synthesis — Rajdeo Mandal's Place in Literary History

## 7.1 The Significance of the Dhanuk Voice

Rajdeo Mandal's most irreducible literary-historical contribution is his status as the first Dhanuk-caste writer to produce a substantial, multi-generic body of literary work in Maithili. This is not merely a matter of biographical identity — it is a matter of epistemic and aesthetic consequence. The Dhanuk community's specific experience — its particular relationship to land, labour, and social hierarchy in Mithila; its specific folk cultural traditions; its characteristic forms of social solidarity and conflict — had never before found full literary expression in Maithili. Mandal's work gives this experience literary form for the first time, and in doing so expands the representational range of Maithili literature in a way that no purely aesthetic innovation could achieve.

## 7.2 The Question of Language and Register

Mandal's gamaya Maithili — the vernacular of OBC village communities, with its specific phonological features, proverbs, idioms, and expressive patterns — is itself a literary achievement. Against the tendency of mainstream Maithili literary culture to treat the upper-caste (Brahmin-Kayastha) literary register as the only legitimate literary language, Mandal asserts the literariness of gamaya speech: its capacity for lyric intensity,

narrative richness, dramatic force, and social insight. This linguistic assertion is the literary equivalent of Gangesa's epistemological insistence that valid cognition (prama) must be grounded in the actual object of knowledge rather than in received tradition — the actual language of the Dhanuk community rather than the received language of the Brahmin literary establishment.

## 7.3 The Videha Movement and Digital Cultural Democracy

The Videha Digital Library's archiving of Mandal's ten works makes his literature accessible to readers globally — far beyond the geographical and linguistic limits of the Maithili-speaking community of Bihar and Nepal. This digital accessibility is a form of cultural democracy: it means that Mandal's work can be read, studied, and engaged with by scholars of Dalit and subaltern literature, Indian vernacular modernism, post-colonial studies, and comparative literature, not merely by specialist Maithili readers. The Videha project thus performs a double function: it preserves Maithili's parallel literary tradition and it opens it to the wider world of literary scholarship.

## 7.4 Concluding Assessment

Rajdeo Mandal stands as one of the most important literary figures in contemporary Maithili literature — a poet of genuine excellence, a novelist of social-realist power, a dramatist of community insight, and a screenplay pioneer. His work represents the fullest literary expression of the Videha Parallel Literature Movement's project of cultural democratisation and subaltern assertion. Applied through the Navya Nyaya framework: his work achieves prama (valid cognition) about the social reality of Mithila's OBC communities through the pratyaksha of first-hand community experience; it corrects the bhrama of mainstream Maithili literature's false universalisation of upper-caste experience; and it provides through literary sabda (testimony) an authoritative account of a social world that had previously been unable to speak in its own name within the institutions of Maithili literature.

The Navya Nyaya tradition of Mithila — the tradition of Gangesa Upadhyaya, who himself came from a socially marginalised family — demands rigorous honesty in the pursuit of valid knowledge. Rajdeo Mandal's literature enacts this demand in the domain of social and cultural representation: it insists on the pratyaksha validity of subaltern experience against the anumana-based condescensions of the Brahmin literary establishment, and in doing so advances the democratic project of Maithili literature as a whole.References and Bibliography

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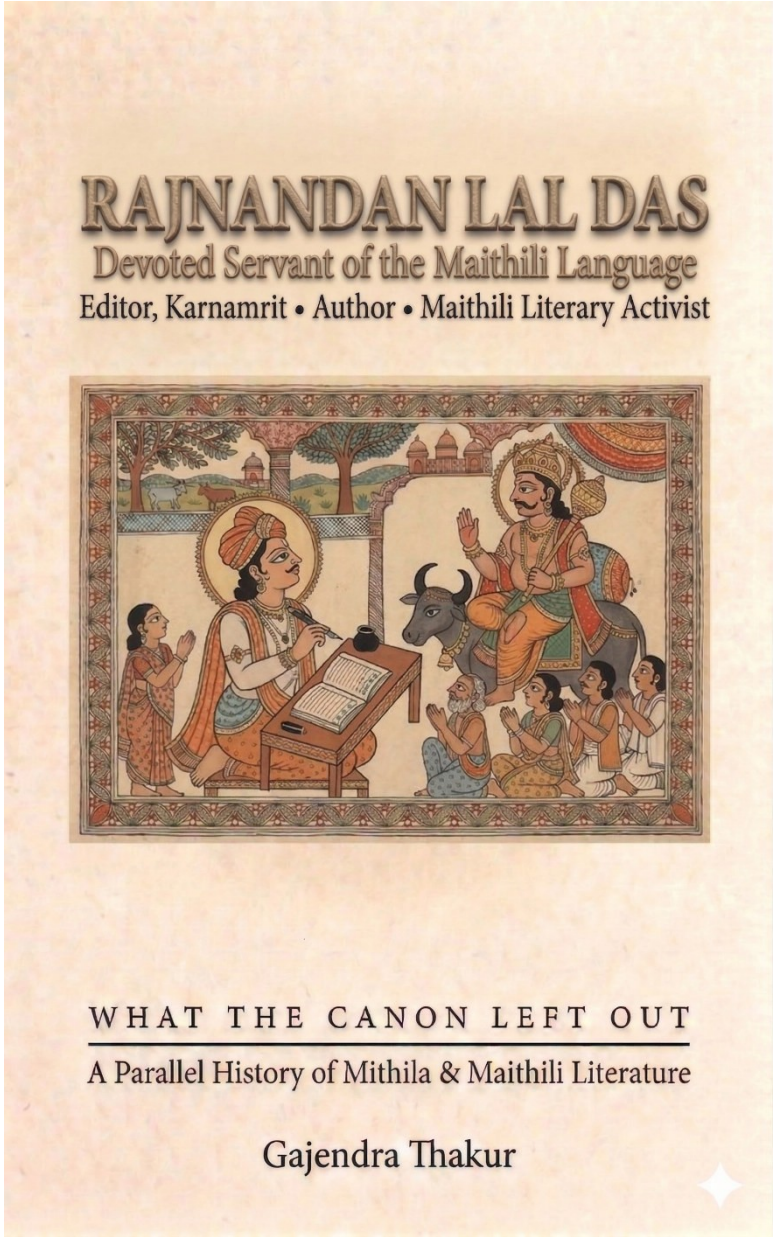
**LESSON 061 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**




# Rajnandan Lal Das

*Devoted Servant of the Maithili Language*

Editor, Karnamrit • Author • Maithili Literary Activist

**AT A GLANCE**

**Full Name:** Rajnandan Lal Das (राजनन्दन लाल दास)

**Born:** 5 January 1934

**Maternal Birthplace:** Patori, Panchagachia, Saharsa, Bihar

**Paternal Village:** Gonoun (Gonon), Ghanshyampur, Darbhanga, Bihar

**Father:** Late Mani Lal Das (worked at Madhubani Court; later in electricity dept., Pandaul)

**Mother:** Late Vidyadevi (devout and skilled homemaker)

**Wife:** Rajeshwari Devi (died 24 December 2015, at age 74, in Kolkata)

**Children:** Three sons, two daughters; also two daughters who remained celibate to care for parents

**Education:** Matriculation 1949; M.A. Political Science, Calcutta University, 1960; Diploma in Sales Management & Market Research, School of Business Management, Calcutta University

**Career:** Sales Officer/Representative, prestigious engineering/consulting equipment company, Kolkata; later Sales Manager

**Passed Away:** 4 July 2021 (04-07-2021), at his Kolkata residence, at the age of 87

**Primary Journal:** Karnamrit (कर्णामृत) — Maithili fortnightly, 1981–2019, 156 issues

**Earlier Journal:** Akhar (आखर) — 1967, ran for approximately one year; co-published with others

**ISBNed Source:** Videha Rajnandan Lal Das Visheshank, ISBN 978-93-340-1588-1

# 1. Introduction: A Quiet Giant of Maithili Literature

Rajnandan Lal Das (राजनन्दन लाल दास) stands among the most selfless, dedicated, and quietly consequential figures in the history of modern Maithili literature. For over four decades, from 1981 until 2019, he single-handedly edited, published, marketed, and sustained the Maithili fortnightly journal Karnamrit (कर्णामृत) — 156 issues — from Kolkata, doing so without any institutional financial backing and without any expectation of reward or recognition.

The Videha Rajnandan Lal Das Visheshank (विदेह राजनन्दन लाल दास विशेषांक, ISBN 978-93-340-1588-1) — a 185-page commemorative special issue compiled by Videha editor Gajendra Thakur and published by the First Maithili Fortnightly eJournal — serves as the primary and most authoritative source for this report. It comprises 28 essays and tributes by scholars, journalists, nephews, editors, readers, and contemporaries who knew Rajnandan Lal Das personally. The sheer number and diversity of these testimonies constitute a rich, multi-perspectival portrait of a man who was, in the words of one contributor, 'Maithilaak Dadhichi' — the Dadhichi of Mithila, who sacrificed everything for his language.

This expanded report synthesises all available information from the Videha Visheshank along with other published sources into a comprehensive account of his life, work, philosophy, and legacy.

# 2. Family Background and Early Life

## 2.1 Origins and Family Circumstances

Rajnandan Lal Das was born on 5 January 1934 in Patori, Panchagachia, Saharsa district — his mother's village (maatrika graam). His ancestral (paitrik) village was Gonoun (Gonon) in Ghanshyampur, Darbhanga — the cultural heartland of Mithila. The Visheshank records that even before his birth, the family had suffered financial difficulty: 'khet pathar gaahi birahi bilaat gelai' (fields and stones crumbled; poverty prevailed).

His father, Mani Lal Das, worked initially at Madhubani Court as a legal practitioner and later took up employment in the electricity department at Pandaul Circle under the then-Raj Darbhanga. A maternal uncle (pita's elder brother — pititti Buccheelal Das) was a Dewan in the household of a Muslim zamindar in Sakri. Despite financial pressures, the family maintained its dignity and the children were encouraged to pursue education.

His mother, Vidyadevi, is described in the Visheshank as 'a skilled homemaker and deeply devout woman' — the kind of steadying presence that provided moral orientation in a household buffeted by economic uncertainty.

### 2.2 Schooling in Bihar

Rajnandan Lal Das received his primary education at his village school and for some time at Madhubani. For classes 4 through 7, he studied at Pandaul Middle School. Classes 8 through 11 were completed at S.K.H.E. School, Pandaul. It was during class 8, when Maithili became his elective subject, that the decisive seed was planted.

> *“Pavi likhba je nai bajai bah nij maatribhasha Maithili... (Write, but do not speak ill of your mother tongue Maithili)”* — — a verse by Kavivara Sitaram Jha that profoundly moved the young Rajnandan Lal Das

This poem's impact on the young Rajnandan was transformative. According to multiple contributors to the Visheshank, this is the moment his lifelong devotion to Maithili was kindled. He passed his Matriculation examination in 1949.

## 3. Arrival in Kolkata and Education

### 3.1 The Move to Kolkata

After passing matriculation in 1949, Rajnandan Lal Das wished to pursue further education but the family's financial situation was precarious. His elder brother wrote to a maternal relative — Modan Narayan Das — who was living in Kolkata and tutoring the children of a wealthy family. Modan Narayan agreed to take Rajnandan in. The elder brother gave him Rs. 115 and sent him to Kolkata with a simple blessing.

He arrived in Kolkata and settled in Rajendra Babu Nivas on College Street, where many Bihari students and Maithili-speaking residents lived. He supported himself by giving tuition and enrolled at Vidyasagar College, attending evening classes. The principal of Vidyasagar College is described as 'extremely kind and a great supporter of intelligent students.' This environment of scholarly aspiration shaped his intellectual direction.

### 3.2 Academic Achievements

Rajnandan Lal Das completed his Master of Arts in Political Science from Calcutta University in 1960. He then went on to earn a Diploma in Sales Management and Market Research from the School of Business Management, Calcutta University — a qualification that would later serve his career and, crucially, enable him to market and distribute Karnamrit across India.

The Visheshank notes that in College Street, apart from intellectual discussions, conversations about the development and upliftment of the Maithili language and Mithila culture were constant — and the influence of towering Maithili figures like Babu Saheb Chaudhary, Devanandlal Jha, and Dr. Prabodh Narayan Singh upon the young Rajnandan was profound and decisive.

## 4. Corporate Career: Sales Manager and Marketing Strategist

Upon completing his education, Rajnandan Lal Das joined a prestigious private consulting equipment company in Kolkata as a Sales Officer/Representative. He rose to become a Sales Manager — a position he held at multiple consulting/construction equipment companies in Kolkata over the course of his professional career.

His nephew Ramesh Lal Das, writing in the Visheshank, provides a remarkable account of how Rajnandan Lal Das turned his corporate career into an instrument of Maithili literature promotion:

> *“During the day he marketed the company's products, and in the evenings he marketed Karnamrit and other published Maithili books. Kolkata Product Consulting Equipment — throughout all of India, the company's brand sold under the name R.L. Das.”* — — Ramesh Lal Das (nephew), Visheshank p. 74

His business travel across India — required by his corporate role — became a vehicle for expanding Karnamrit's subscriber base. On every trip to any city, he would visit Maithili-speaking diaspora communities, cultivate interest in Maithili literature, and secure new subscribers. The Visheshank records that he would spend entire months traveling, city by city, in this double mission. The result was that Karnamrit had readers in every state of India and in some parts of Nepal.

His nephew further notes that Rajnandan Lal Das was universally accepted and respected in Kolkata — 'by Maithils, Bengalis, and company officers equally' — attributing this to his 'unpretentious, selfless, pure-hearted manner of dealing with everyone.'

## 5. The Maithili Movement: Organizational Work

### 5.1 Mithila Lok Sangh and Akhil Bharatiya Mithila Sangh (1958 onward)

Well before founding Karnamrit, Rajnandan Lal Das was deeply involved in the organizational work of the Maithili movement. In 1958, he enrolled as a volunteer (swayamsevak) in the then Mithila Lok Sangh. This organization later merged with another, and on 26 January 1958 both united as the Akhil Bharatiya Mithila Sangh (All India Mithila Association). The credit for this merger went to Dr. Lakshman Jha, Dr. Brajkishore Verma 'Manipadma', and Dr. Harimohan Jha.

Rajnandan Lal Das served as Secretary of the Akhil Bharatiya Mithila Sangh — 1962 onward. This was a democratically recognized position, which the Visheshank describes as a mark of his popularity within the Maithili literary and cultural community of Kolkata.

### 5.2 Mithila Darshan Company and Akhar Journal

He served as Secretary of Mithila Darshan Pra. Ltd. Company — 1963 onward — a publishing entity associated with the Maithili journal Mithila Darshan. In 1967, he participated in the founding of the 'Akhar' (आखर) journal, along with others including Kirtinanarayan Mishra and Birendra Mallik. Akhar ran for

approximately one year — the Visheshank notes it was 'very popular for a while, but like most Maithili journals, it was short-lived.' This experience taught Rajnandan Lal Das that the survival of a Maithili journal required extraordinary commitment and resilience.

### 5.3 Maithili Sangram Samiti

He was also associated with the Maithili Sangram Samiti — 1967 — an activist organization working for Maithili's rights in education and official recognition. His consistent association with multiple organizations across two decades before founding Karnamrit demonstrates that his commitment to the Maithili cause was deep-rooted and long-standing — not a late-life avocation.

## 6. Karnamrit: The Life's Work (1981–2019)

### 6.1 Foundation and Philosophy

The founding of Karnamrit (कर्णामृत) in 1981 marked the beginning of Rajnandan Lal Das's most sustained and consequential contribution to Maithili letters. The journal was founded under the auspices of the Karnagoshti (कर्णगोष्ठी) — an association representing the Karna Kayastha community of Mithila. The founding editor was Arjunlal Karna, who handed over the responsibility to Rajnandan Lal Das, trusting him completely.

Initially, some accused Rajnandan Lal Das of publishing only Karna Kayastha writers in the journal. This charge was comprehensively refuted — a 2016 interview in Karnamrit itself, with Laxman Jha Sagar, demonstrated that the journal had consistently published writers from all communities and all castes. The accusation was 'proven false on the basis of evidence,' as the Visheshank records.

Karnamrit's philosophy, as reflected in Rajnandan Lal Das's own editorials, was clear: Maithili is the folk language (lok bhasha) of Mithila — carrier of the consciousness of all its people — and must not remain the exclusive domain of any one caste or class. He declared: 'Maithili Mithilaak lok bhasha chhai, lok chetanaak sanvaahak chhai' — Maithili is the people's language of Mithila, the carrier of popular consciousness.

## 6.2 Structure and Features of Karnamrit

Karnamrit was a fortnightly (dwaimas) journal. It became particularly celebrated for its Shaaradiya Visheshank — the annual autumn/Shaarad special issue published in October–December — which was considered a landmark literary publication each year, gathering the best of Maithili poetry, fiction, drama, and Mithila art. These seasonal special issues were collector's items, eagerly awaited by subscribers across India.

The journal also published special thematic issues — issues devoted to folk art, women's writing, drama, children's literature. Importantly, Rajnandan Lal Das used the journal as a platform not just to publish established writers, but to actively discover and nurture new voices. The Visheshank notes that 'many a writer's first Maithili composition was published in Karnamrit,' and these writers later went on to become significant contributors to the language.

A defining feature was the covers: Mithila painting (Madhubani art) consistently graced the cover of Karnamrit, making visual promotion of the traditional art form an intrinsic part of the journal's identity.

## 6.3 156 Issues Over 38 Years: Sustaining the Unsustainable

Between 1981 and 2019, Rajnandan Lal Das edited 156 issues of Karnamrit — a span of nearly four decades. The journal ran without any institutional financial support, sustained entirely through subscriptions, community donations, and Rajnandan Lal Das's own labour and resources. Multiple contributors to the Visheshank describe how he managed this against enormous odds:

- He traveled all over India on his corporate sales rounds, using every trip to visit local Maithili communities and add new subscribers, personally collecting subscription fees.
- He absorbed many costs himself — including printing costs — often at personal financial sacrifice.
- He faced health crises several times (including a brain haemorrhage mentioned in the Visheshank) but returned each time to continue the journal.
- He bore the devastating blow of his wife Rajeshwari Devi's death (24 December 2015, at age 74) and continued uninterrupted.
- He also edited Akhar (आखर) alongside his other responsibilities at various points.

> *“His contribution to Maithili journalism is so permanently memorable that no one comparable can be found in the entire Maithili literary landscape. In Hindi journalism, only Mahavir Prasad Dwivedi comes to mind as a comparable figure.”* — — Sharadanand Das Parimal, Visheshank

### 6.4 The Nepal Issue and Final Phase

Even in his final years, Rajnandan Lal Das continued to innovate. A special Nepal issue of Karnamrit — edited in association with the then-assistant editor Chandresh — was received with great acclaim. This demonstrated his vision of Maithili as a transnational language spanning India and Nepal, not confined to any one administrative boundary.

At 85 years old, he wrote in one of his editorials: 'Maithili kein ekta aur Bhagirath chaahi' — Maithili needs one more Bhagirath (the sage who brought the Ganga to earth, a metaphor for the need for a heroic saviour for the language).

## 7. Published Works: Books and Edited Volumes

### 7.1 Original Creative Works

Despite devoting the overwhelming majority of his energy to Karnamrit, Rajnandan Lal Das authored several original works:

- Santo (सन्तो) — A Maithili play (natak), 1970. Described in the Visheshank as a 'revolutionary play for the various rights of Maithilis' (Maithilik vibhinn adhikaar hetu kraantikari natak). Its successful stage performances are documented. The play reflects his Marxist/socialist intellectual orientation of the era and his belief in the power of theatre as a vehicle for social consciousness-raising.
- Chitra-Vichitra (चित्रा-विचित्रा) — An essay and article collection (aalekh sangrah), 2006. Multiple contributors to the Visheshank discuss this work, noting that it reflects his views on Maithili literature, society, and culture.
- Prabodh Narayan Singh (Vinibandh) — A biographical-critical essay on the life and work of Dr. Prabodh Narayan Singh, published by the Sahitya

Akademi in 2012. This is significant: the Sahitya Akademi imprimatur lends institutional recognition to his scholarly work.

- Mithila-Maithili ke Vikasme Karnagoshti evam Karnamrit ka Yogdan (1974–2011) — A research monograph documenting the contribution of the Karnagoshti organisation and Karnamrit journal to the development of Mithila and Maithili. The publication year is not confirmed.

### 7.2 Edited Volumes

- Mithilak Dadhichi Bhola Lal Das evam Rajeshwar Jha: Vyaktitva o Krititva (1978) — A volume on the personality and works of Bhola Lal Das and Rajeshwar Jha (second generation) foundational figures in modern Maithili.
- Munshi Raghunanadan Das: Vyaktitva o Krititva (1983) — A biographical-critical volume on Munshi Raghunanandan Das, who lived 1860–1945 and wrote the Maithili work Subhadra Haran.
- Karnamrit (fortnightly journal) — 1981 to present, 156 issues edited.

The Visheshank also records that Rajnandan Lal Das played a significant facilitating role in the publication of works by other Maithili writers — including the famous novelist Manipadma and poet Ramanand Renu (author of Dudh-Phool) — through the Karnagoshti publication wing. He helped writers get their manuscripts published, often partially subsidising the costs himself.

## 8. Political Consciousness and Anti-Caste Philosophy

### 8.1 Early Leftist Engagement

The Visheshank makes a careful and nuanced observation: Rajnandan Lal Das was, up until 1967, a card-holding member of the Communist Party of India (CPI). His study of Marxist-Leninist thought and the Russian Revolution during his time at Calcutta University — where left-wing politics was the dominant intellectual current — shaped his early political formation.

However, the Visheshank's critical essay by Ashish Anchinhaar notes that 'not a single article in Chitra-Vichitra shows any trace of his leftist form.' The assessment is that the pressures of livelihood and the conservative cultural world of Maithili literary advocacy gradually displaced his explicit socialist

politics, even while he retained a genuine concern for the common people and a distaste for caste discrimination.

## 8.2 Breaking Caste Barriers in Maithili Publishing

Rajnandan Lal Das's most concrete and practically significant anti-caste contribution was the consistent, deliberate editorial policy of Karnamrit: the journal published writers from all castes and communities without discrimination. In a Maithili literary world long dominated by Maithil Brahmins and, to a lesser degree, Karna Kayasthas, this was a meaningful and consequential editorial stance.

> *"He broke the literary caste barrier — Rajnandan ji crossed the caste boundary of literature."* — — Munnaji (contributor), Visheshank

He strongly advocated the idea that Maithili is a lok bhasha — the language of all the people of Mithila — and not the exclusive property of any one caste or community. His editorials repeatedly argued against the casteisation of Maithili culture and for an inclusive literary ecology.

## 8.3 Campaign for Maithili as Medium of Primary Education

One of the causes closest to Rajnandan Lal Das's heart was the introduction of Maithili as the medium of primary school education in Bihar. He continued to agitate for this cause even in his final years. At the age of 84, on 14 February 2017, he wrote a petition to the President of India requesting that Maithili be made the medium of primary education. The President of India directed Bihar's Chief Secretary to take cognisance of the petition. Despite sympathetic political responses from Maithili legislators and state-level advocacy, the goal remained unrealised during his lifetime.

The Visheshank's essay by Dilip Kumar Jha records that Rajnandan Lal Das was one of three towering figures who consistently championed this cause — the others being Dr. Jaykant Mishra and Pandit Chandranath Mishra 'Amar'. He agitated through letters, journal editorials, and personal advocacy whenever opportunities arose.

## 9. Honours, Recognition, and Awards

Rajnandan Lal Das received recognition from multiple institutions across the Maithili-speaking world, though the Visheshank notes that he was always indifferent to personal honours, preferring the publication of a book over being garland-draped on a stage:

- Mithila Vibhuti — Vidyapati Seva Sansthan, Darbhanga — Honour and citation, 1999
- Kalyan Pathadayini Hutoun — Honour and citation, 2003
- Karnagoshti, Dhanbad — Honour and citation, 2004
- Mithila Sanskritik Parishad, Jamshedpur — Honour, 2004
- Chitragupta Sabha, Patna — Honour and citation, 2004
- Vidyapati Smarak Manch, Kolkata — Honour and citation, 2008

The Visheshank also records that the Mumbai Karnagoshti invited him to be honoured at their function, but Rajnandan Lal Das proposed instead that the money allocated for the function be used to publish a book. The Mumbai Karnagoshti agreed, and the book was published — a telling illustration of his priority of substance over ceremony.

The Visheshank notes further that Rajnandan Lal Das himself produced 18 posthumous commemorative special issues of Karnamrit honouring deceased Maithili literary figures — demonstrating that he spent his energy honouring others rather than seeking honour for himself.

## 10. Personal Life and Character

### 10.1 Marriage and Family

Rajnandan Lal Das married Rajeshwari Devi, who became his steadfast companion and, according to multiple contributors, a silent partner in his literary mission. She passed away on 24 December 2015 at their Kolkata home, at the age of 74. The Visheshank records the apprehension felt by friends and observers when she died — fearing that such a devastating personal blow might interrupt his work — but Rajnandan Lal Das's resolve proved 'uninterrupted' (apratihat).

He had five children in total — three sons and two daughters. Two of his daughters chose to remain celibate lifelong in order to care for their parents — a devotion noted with deep respect in the Visheshank.

### 10.2 Personal Qualities as Recalled by Contemporaries

The 28 essays in the Visheshank, spanning a vast range of relationships — nephew, subscriber, fellow traveller, rival, critic, admirer — converge on a consistent portrait:

- Simplicity (saralata) and warmth: He welcomed anyone who arrived at his Kolkata home, regardless of their status. Ajit Kumar Jha (Visheshank) recalls arriving unannounced and being invited to stay and eat — even though Rajnandan Lal Das was himself recovering from a brain haemorrhage at the time.
- Tirelessness in service: He walked the streets of Kolkata distributing Karnamrit, attended meetings and functions where he promoted Maithili literature, and held conversations for hours about the state of the language.
- Financial self-sacrifice: The journal never paid its editor. Every rupee collected from subscribers went towards printing and distribution. His personal resources were used to cover shortfalls.
- Absence of self-promotion: He published no photographs of himself in the journal, sought no personal publicity, and consistently deflected praise towards the language and the cause.
- Mentorship: He is credited by numerous contributors as having actively encouraged young writers — several of whom credit their literary careers to his personal encouragement.
- Health resilience: He suffered a brain haemorrhage and recovered; he suffered other serious illnesses over the years — and each time returned to Karnamrit.

> *"He would rather have a book published than receive a garland on a stage. To him, the book was the honour."* — — Ajit Kumar Jha, Visheshank

## 11. The Karna Community and Mithila's Plural Heritage

Rajnandan Lal Das's biographical and scholarly work about the Karna community is one of the distinctive threads of his contribution. His research

monograph 'Mithila-Maithili ke Vikasme Karnagoshti evam Karnamrit ka Yogdan' documented the Karna Kayastha community's contributions to Mithila's development — an effort at recovering a history that had been partially overshadowed by the dominant narrative of Maithil Brahmin literary culture.

His biographical essays on Bhola Lal Das and Munshi Raghunanadan Lal Das similarly centre figures who, while significant in Maithili literary history, had not received the scholarly attention they deserved. By writing their biographies, Rajnandan Lal Das performed an act of cultural recuperation — bringing overlooked contributors back into the record.

This aspect of his work aligns with the Videha journal's broader parallel history project — the effort to write a more inclusive, democratised history of Maithili literature that acknowledges contributions beyond the dominant caste groups.

## 12. The Kolkata Maithili Diaspora Context

Kolkata has been one of the most important centres of Maithili literary and cultural activity outside of the Mithila heartland. Bihar's economic underdevelopment — especially in the Darbhanga-Madhubani-Saharsa belt — drove large-scale migration to Kolkata from the 19th century onward. The Maithili diaspora in Kolkata established cultural and literary organisations, journals, and networks that kept the language alive far from home.

Rajnandan Lal Das was inspired by the cultural vitality of Bengalis around him. Multiple contributors to the Visheshank note that the passion of Bengali speakers for their language — their book fairs, their literary culture, their willingness to buy books and support writers — was a model that Rajnandan Lal Das wished to replicate for Maithili. He found in Kolkata both a home and a challenge: could Maithili-speakers achieve the same cultural self-confidence and institutional richness?

His answer was to try — with Karnamrit, with book publishing, with community organising, with campaigning for Maithili education rights. The Visheshank's account of his work in Kolkata is simultaneously a history of the Maithili diaspora community's cultural aspirations across several decades.

# 13. Passing and Legacy

## 13.1 Passing

Rajnandan Lal Das passed away at his Kolkata residence on 4 July 2021 (04-07-2021), at the age of 87. The Visheshank records:

> *“On 4 July 2021, the entire Maithili community was plunged into grief. It felt as though some priceless treasure of Mithila had been lost. The eyes of every Mithila-Maithili servant across the country and abroad welled with tears.”* — — Vijay Issar 'Vats', Visheshank (dated: Begusaray, 15 October 2021, Vijayadashami)

The obituary note published by Maithil Manch (maithilmanch.in), written by Dr. Ravindra Kumar Chaudhary, had earlier confirmed the more specific time as 'around 1 PM at his Kolkata residence' — the Visheshank confirms the date as 4 July 2021. He was referred to as 'Maithili ka Dadhichi' — the Dadhichi of Maithili, a mythological analogy for a being who sacrifices everything for a higher cause.

## 13.2 His Legacy

- 156 issues of Karnamrit (1981–2019) — an unmatched record of Maithili journal publication from a single editor-publisher
- 18 posthumous commemorative special issues of Karnamrit for deceased Maithili luminaries
- Published works including the revolutionary play Santo (1970), essay collection Chitra-Vichitra (2006), and the Sahitya Akademi-published monograph on Prabodh Narayan Singh (2012)
- Edited biographical volumes on Bhola Lal Das (1978) and Munshi Raghunanandan Das (1983)
- Research monograph on Karnagoshti's contribution to Maithili development
- Direct mentorship and encouragement of a generation of Maithili writers across India
- Continuous advocacy — through editorials, letters, and personal activism — for Maithili primary education
- Promotion of Mithila painting through Karnamrit's covers and special features
- Building a pan-India (and partially Nepal) subscriber network for a Maithili journal purely through personal effort

His final aspiration, expressed in an editorial at age 85, was that Maithili needs 'one more Bhagirath' — a heroic figure to secure the language's rightful place in public life, especially in education. He himself was that Bhagirath for his generation, even if he would never have accepted the title.

## 14. The Videha Visheshank: A Primary Source

The Videha Rajnandan Lal Das Visheshank (ISBN 978-93-340-1588-1), published by Videha — First Maithili Fortnightly eJournal (www.videha.co.in, ISSN 2229-547X, edited by Gajendra Thakur) — is a 185-page special issue entirely devoted to Rajnandan Lal Das. It is a print-on-demand volume available through Videha and is the most comprehensive primary document on his life and work available.

The volume contains 28 essays and memoirs by contributors including: Mukesh Dutta, Dilip Kumar Jha, Ajit Jha, Ashok, Jagdish Chander Thakur 'Anil', Chandana Dutta, Amod Jha, Akhilesh Kumar Jha, Chandresh, Jitendra Nath Dutta, Kanchan Kanth, Laxman Jha 'Sagar', Ramesh Lal Das (nephew), Sharadanand Das Parimal, Nabonarayan Mishra, Surendra Thakur, Sudhir, Kameshwar Jha 'Kamal', Pradeep Bihari, Arvind Thakur (on Chitra-Vichitra), Vijay Issar 'Vats', Shashi Shankar Srinivas (on his drama), Shailendra Mishra, Ashish Neeraj, Munnaji, Ashish Anuchinhaar, and Nabonarayan Mishra (Appendix from Videha Sadeha 18).

The editor, Gajendra Thakur, notes in his preface that the special issue was announced while Rajnandan Lal Das was still alive, but by the time of publication he had passed away. He writes: 'Whatever could be done should be understood as a humble offering. In the future, we will certainly digitise the handwritten contributions that could not be typed in time.'

## 15. Complete Biographical Summary

**Name:** Rajnandan Lal Das | राजनन्दन लाल दास

**Born:** 5 January 1934, Patori, Panchagachia, Saharsa, Bihar (maternal village)

**Paternal Home:** Gonoun, Ghanshyampur, Darbhanga, Bihar

**Father:** Late Mani Lal Das (court practitioner, electricity dept.)

**Mother:** Late Vidyadevi

**Schooling:** Village school, Madhubani; Pandaul Middle School; S.K.H.E. School Pandaul (Matric 1949)

**College:** Vidyasagar College, Kolkata (evening, self-supported via tuition)

**Degrees:** M.A. Political Science, Calcutta University, 1960; Diploma Sales Mgmt & Market Research, Calcutta University

**Career:** Sales Representative/Manager, consulting/equipment companies, Kolkata

**Wife:** Rajeshwari Devi (d. 24 December 2015, aged 74, Kolkata)

**Children:** 3 sons, 2 daughters; 2 daughters lifelong celibate for parents' service

**Died:** 4 July 2021, Kolkata residence, aged 87

**Languages:** Maithili (primary), Hindi, Bengali (comprehension)

**Original Books:** Santo (1970, play); Chitra-Vichitra (2006, essays); Prabodh Narayan Singh (2012, biography, Sahitya Akademi); Karnagoshti-Karnamrit Yogdan 1974-2011 (research)

**Edited Books:** Bhola Lal Das & Rajeshwar Jha biographies (1978); Munshi Raghunanandan Das biography (1983)

**Journal Founded:** Akhar (आखर), 1967 (co-founder); Karnamrit (कर्णामृत), 1981–2019, 156 issues

**Organisations:** Akhil Bharatiya Mithila Sangh (Secretary, 1962); Mithila Sangram Samiti (1967); Mithila Darshan Pra. Ltd. (Secretary, 1963)

**Political History:** CPI card-holder until 1967; later non-partisan Maithili activist

**Awards:** Mithila Vibhuti (1999); Kalyan Pathadayini Hutoun (2003); Karnagoshti Dhanbad (2004); Mithila Sanskritik Parishad Jamshedpur (2004); Chitragupta Sabha Patna (2004); Vidyapati Smarak Manch Kolkata (2008)

**Legacy Title:** Maithilaak Dadhichi — The Dadhichi of Mithila

**Primary Source:** Videha Rajnandan Lal Das Visheshank, 185 pp., ISBN 978-93-340-1588-1, Editor Gajendra Thakur, Videha (ISSN 2229-547X)

## Summary of Key Facts

**Born:** 25 January 1934, Ghanshyampur-Gonoun, Darbhanga, Bihar

**Died:** July 2021, Kolkata (aged ~87)

**Education:** M.A., Political Science, University of Calcutta

**Profession:** Marketing Manager (corporate); Editor & Writer (literary)

**Primary Journal:** Karnamrit (कर्णामृत), Kolkata-based Maithili journal

**Editorial Span:** 1981–2019, 156 issues edited

**Other Journal:** Akhar (आखर), also edited

**Literary Genre:** Drama (Natak), Essays (Aalekh), Biography (Vinibandh)

**Key Books:** Santo (drama); Chitra-Vichitra (essays); Karnagoshti; biographies of Bhola Lal Das, Raghunanandan Lal Das, Dr. Prabodh Narayan Singh

**Community:** Karna Kayastha (Mithila)

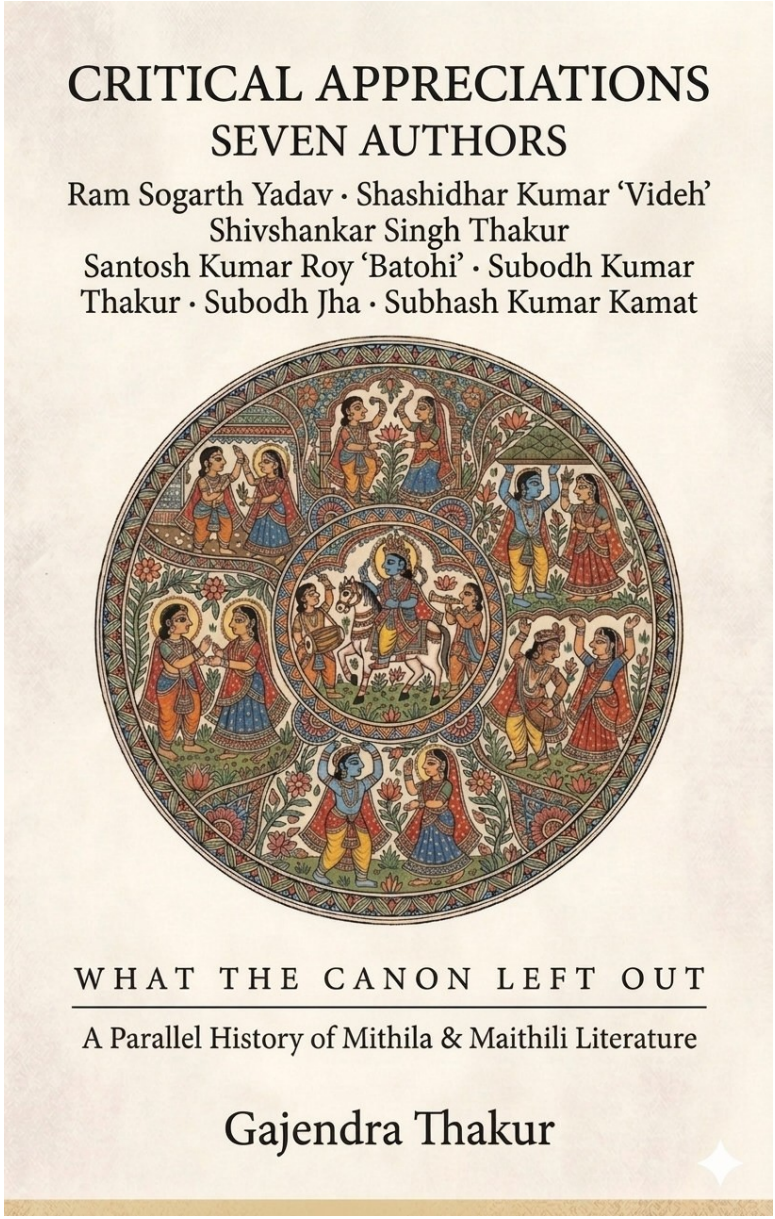
**Epithet:** Maithilīk Ananya Sevak — Devoted/Incomparable Servant of Maithili

## 16. Sources


- Videha Rajnandan Lal Das Visheshank (Primary) — 185-page special issue, ISBN 978-93-340-1588-1, Editor: Gajendra Thakur, Videha — First Maithili Fortnightly eJournal (www.videha.co.in, ISSN 2229-547X). Contains 28 essays by scholars, contemporaries, family members.
- Maithil Manch (maithilmanch.in) — Obituary by Dr. Ravindra Kumar Chaudhary, July 2021.
- Videha Pothi Archive (www.videha.co.in/pothi.htm) — Maithili Books Archive where Rajnandan Lal Das's works are listed.

- Videha Parallel History of Maithili Literature — Gajendra Thakur, www.videha.co.in, for wider Maithili literary-historical context.
- Wikipedia and standard sources on Maithili language and literature for background context.

**LESSON 062 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**



## CRITICAL APPRECIATIONS

*Ram Sogarth Yadav · Shashidhar Kumar 'Videh' · Shivshankar Singh Thakur · Santosh Kumar Roy 'Batohi' · Subodh Kumar Thakur · Subodh Jha · Subhash Kumar Kamat*

*Indian & Western Literary Theory · Videha Parallel History Framework · Navya-Nyāya of Gaṅgeśa*

# RAM SOGARTH YADAV

राम सोगारथ यादव

*OBC-Yadav Voice · Social Protest Poet · Short Fiction Writer · Democratic Commitment*

### Archive Presence & Works

Sadeha 19 (Prelim_19): Bīhani Kathā 'Sapanā Sapane Achi' (pp. 200–202) | Sadeha 19 Poetry: Gariba / Deśa Prati Sneh / Samundara Pāra / Hamara Binatī / He Yuvā Uṭhū / Rokū Dahejakeṃ / Lobha Kie? / Mahānubhāva Jyū! / Ghūsakeṃ Jūsa Bandu Karu / Bhuta Lāgala Katekekeṃ / Nora Birāna Bhela / Pralaya Ahīṃ Chī / Nava Mithilāka Nirmāṇa Karaita Calū / and many more (pp. 765+)

Ram Sogarth Yadav is one of the most significant OBC (Other Backward Class) voices in the Videha archive. His surname Yadav immediately identifies him within the Yadav community — the largest OBC caste in Bihar, historically associated with cattle-herding and agriculture, and in the modern era the political base of Lalu Prasad Yadav's RJD party. The given name combination 'Sogarth' is unusual and regional. His contributions to Sadeha 19 span both bīhani kathā and a substantial poetry sequence. The bīhani kathā 'Sapanā Sapane Achi' (A Dream Is Only a Dream) suggests the characteristic gap between aspiration and reality in the lives of Bihar's rural and working poor. His poetry sequence is a remarkable catalogue of Bihar-Mithila's social crises: Gariba (The Poor), Deśa Prati Sneh (Love for the Country), Samundara Pāra (Across the Ocean — migration), Hamara Binatī (My Petition), He Yuvā Uṭhū

(O Youth, Rise), Rokū Dahejakeṃ (Stop Dowry), Lobha Kie? (Why Greed?), Ghūsakeṃ Jūsa Bandu Karu (Stop the Juice of Bribery), Bhuta Lāgala Katekekeṃ (How Many Have Been Possessed/Haunted), Pralaya Ahīṃ Chī (You Are the Cataclysm), Nava Mithilāka Nirmāṇa Karaita Calū (Let Us Build New Mithila).

## Thematic & Critical Analysis

Yadav's poetry is a programmatic social manifesto in lyric form. Each title encodes a specific social problem: dowry, bribery, greed, youth unemployment, migration, poverty. The sequential presentation creates a cumulative portrait of Bihar-Mithila's social crisis that is both documentation and call to action. He Yuvā Uṭhū (O Youth, Rise) places him in the tradition of social mobilisation poetry — the Maithili equivalent of the progressive 'Navgeet' tradition in Hindi. Nava Mithilāka Nirmāṇa Karaita Calū (Let Us Build New Mithila) is an affirmative conclusion: the series of problem-naming poems concludes with a constructive vision. Pralaya Ahīṃ Chī (You Are the Cataclysm) addresses an unnamed second person — presumably the social system, political power, or human greed — as the agent of destruction.

## Theoretical Frameworks

Rasa: Vīra (heroic call to action — He Yuvā Uṭhū, Nava Mithilā) combined with Karuṇa (pathos of Gariba, Nora Birāna Bhela) and Raudra (righteous anger against corruption — Ghūsakeṃ Jūsa Bandu Karu). Navya-Nyāya anumāna: each social-problem poem proceeds from observed hetu (specific social fact) to sādhya (critique/call to action) through the vyāpti of social injustice. Lohia's socialist critique (which underpins the OBC political tradition Yadav belongs to): the framework for his consistent address to Bihar's most marginalised communities. The Videha Parallel History: his OBC-Yadav voice fills a significant representational gap in Maithili literature's historically Brahmin-dominated canon.

## Select Bibliography

Yadav, Ram Sogarth. Works in Videha Sadeha 19 (Prelim_19). ISSN 2229-547X. www.videha.co.in. | Bharatamuni. Nāṭyaśāstra. Tr. Ghosh. ASB,

1951. | Gaṅgeśa. Tattvacintāmaṇi. Hackett, 2004. | Lohia, R.M. Marx, Gandhi and Socialism. Hyderabad: Navahind, 1963.

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**DR. SHASHIDHAR KUMAR 'VIDEH'**

डॉ॰ शशिधर कुमार 'विदेह'

*Science Writer · Children's Poet · Literary Critic · Multi-Genre Renaissance Figure*

## Archive Presence & Works

Sadeha 7: Kī Iēha Kahābaichha Sunnaratā (poetry) | Sadeha 9: Dākṣiṇī Dhruva + science fiction (bāla) | Sadeha 10: Gāmaka Jīnagī | Sadeha 11: Ambarā (review) + poetry | Sadeha 12: Pūṇā Pravāsa | Sadeha 13: Poetry | Sadeha 16: Ozone / Pradūṣaṇa (pp. 721–726) | Sadeha 17: Gāmaka Śakala Sūrata review + Bāla kavitā | Sadeha 18: Anilajī v&k + Bhūkampa bāla sci-fi | Sadeha 19: Kichu Bāla Kavitā (pp. 1004–1173) | Sadeha 20: 6 kavitā + 14 bāla kavitā + sacitra | Sadeha 21: Atal Bihārī tribute | Sadeha 30: Reviews | Sadeha 36: 'Uṛi Ne Sakī Par Ciraṛī Chī Hama' + Madhusravanī Gīta + Sinuradānaka Gīta

Dr. Shashidhar Kumar 'Videh' (adopting the pen-name Videh from Videha/Mithila, the ancient kingdom) is the most prolific and generically diverse contributor in the entire Videha archive among the 19 authors under consideration, with confirmed presence across at least 14 Sadeha volumes. He is simultaneously a scientist/science communicator (South Pole narrative, ozone/pollution writing, earthquake science fiction), children's poet and educator (the enormous 170-page bāla kavitā section in Sadeha 19, pp. 1004–1173, is unprecedented in any single Sadeha), literary critic (reviews of Gāmaka Jīnagī, Ambarā, and Gāmaka Śakala Sūrata), cultural essayist (Atal Bihārī tribute, Madhusravanī gīta, Sinuradānaka gīta), and lyric poet (Kī Iēha Kahābaichha Sunnaratā — What Is This Called Beauty?). His pen-name Videh is the classical name of the Maithili kingdom — he is thus positioning himself as the inheritor of the Videha civilisational tradition.

## Thematic & Critical Analysis

Shashidhar Kumar Videh represents the Videha Parallel History's vision of the complete Maithili intellectual: a figure who does not confine himself to one genre or register but engages the full range of Maithili literary and intellectual life. His science writing for children — the South Pole narrative, the earthquake science fiction, the ozone/pollution essays — fills a critical gap in Maithili children's literature: the absence of science-based literary content that connects children to the modern world. The 170-page bāla kavitā section in Sadeha 19 is the most sustained single children's poetry contribution in the archive. His literary criticism (reviews) demonstrates engagement with the evaluative-scholarly tradition, while his cultural essays (Madhusravanī gīta — the women's ritual song tradition) connect him to Mithila's folk heritage. 'Uṛi Ne Sakī Par Ciraṛī Chī Hama' (I Cannot Fly but I Am a Bird) is a metaphor of constrained aspiration that resonates as a summary of the entire democratic literary tradition the Parallel History documents.

## Theoretical Frameworks

The rasa of science writing for children: Adbhuta-rasa (wonder) is the dominant aesthetic of good science communication — the cultivation of wonder at the natural world as the foundation of scientific curiosity. Gaṅgeśa's epistemology: the science communicator's task is precisely that of transmitting valid knowledge (pramā) about the natural world through accurate testimony (śabda-pramāṇa) to a child audience — the pedagogical project of Navya-Nyāya realised in children's literature. Benjamin's 'The Storyteller': the tension between oral tradition (Videh's folk-cultural content) and modern information (his science writing) in a single corpus enacts Benjamin's analysis of the two great narrative traditions. The Videha Parallel History: Videh's multi-genre presence confirms him as the archive's most versatile contributor.

## Select Bibliography

Kumar, Shashidhar 'Videh'. Works across Videha Sadeha 7, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 30, 36. ISSN 2229-547X. www.videha.co.in. | Benjamin, W. 'The Storyteller.' In Illuminations. Tr. Zohn. NY: Schocken, 1969. | Gaṅgeśa. Tattvacintāmaṇi. Hackett, 2004.

**SHIVSHANKAR SINGH THAKUR**

शिवशंकर सिंह ठाकुर

*Ghazal-Rubaī Poet · Kohbar Imagery · Love Poet · Mithila Ritual Cultural Poet*

## Archive Presence & Works

Sadeha 7 (Prelim_7): Rubaī + Ghazal + Lagaī Chī Ahāṃ Sonā Jakāṃ + Śraddhāñjali | Sadeha 36 (Prelim_36): Kohbaraका Hāla Kahalo Ne Jāya + Āñjana Sāṃ Āñjita Āṃkhi + Luṭā Gelauṃha Hama T Rasteme Yau + Kie Dūresāṃ Jhāṃki Kaṣa Dekhai Chī Yai Kaniyāṃ + He Svarṇamayī + Ahāṃ Chī Katau (pp. 2062–2070)

Shivshankar Singh Thakur appears across two widely separated Sadeha volumes (7 and 36) with contributions that together reveal a poet of consistent classical orientation and rich cultural specificity. His Sadeha 7 ghazals and rubaī alongside the lyric 'Lagaī Chī Ahāṃ Sonā Jakāṃ' (You Seem Like Gold) establish his lyric-amorous register. His Sadeha 36 contributions are among the most culturally specific in the Parallel History: Kohbaraका Hāla Kahalo Ne Jāya (The State of the Kohbar Cannot Be Told) — the kohbar is the ritual wedding chamber of Mithila, decorated with Madhubani paintings of lotus, fish, and the divine couple; its 'state' that 'cannot be told' is both the sanctity of the wedding night and the social conditions surrounding it. 'Āñjana Sāṃ Āñjita Āṃkhi' (Eyes Anointed with Kajal/Collyrium) is a classic Maithili lyric image — the kajal-darkened eye is one of the most recurring images in Maithili love poetry from Vidyapati onwards. 'He Svarṇamayī' (O Golden One) and 'Ahāṃ Chī Katau' (Where Are You?) sustain the lyric-address register.

## Thematic & Critical Analysis

Thakur's use of the kohbar as a central cultural image connects him to the deep cultural geography of Mithila — the wedding chamber, its Madhubani paintings, and the rituals that surround it constitute the most distinctively Maithili cultural space. His Śraddhāñjali (Tribute/Obituary poem) in Sadeha 7 shows his engagement with the commemorative tradition. The sustained use of direct address ('Ahāṃ Chī Katau' — Where Are You?; 'He Svarṇamayī' — O

Golden One) creates an intimacy of lyric address that characterises his style. The question 'Kie Dūresāṃ Jhāṃki Kaṣa Dekhai Chī Yai Kaniyāṃ?' (Why Do You Peek and Look from a Distance, O Bride?) is a classic Maithili image of the shy new bride — but in the contemporary context, such images also carry the weight of cultural critique: is this shyness chosen or imposed?

## Theoretical Frameworks

Vidyapati's padāvalī tradition: the direct address to the beloved ('He Svarṇamayī'), the kajal-darkened eye image, and the kohbar setting all place Thakur's work in direct dialogue with the 15th-century master whose padās established the vocabulary of Maithili amorous verse. Ānandavardhana's dhvani: 'Kohbaraका Hāla Kahalo Ne Jāya' generates multiple resonances — the unspeakable quality of the wedding night, the ritual space that resists verbal description, and the social conditions of Maithili marriage. Navya-Nyāya: the image of the kajal-anointed eye as śabda-pramāṇa — verbal testimony that transmits knowledge of a perceptual experience (beauty) that exceeds direct description. The Videha Parallel History: Thakur's consistent use of specifically Maithili cultural images (kohbar, kajal, kaniyāṃ) grounds his work in the living cultural heritage that the Framework champions.

## Select Bibliography

Thakur, Shivshankar Singh. Works in Videha Sadeha 7 (Prelim_7), Sadeha 36 (Prelim_36). ISSN 2229-547X. www.videha.co.in. | Ānandavardhana. Dhvanyāloka. Tr. Krishnamoorthy. Dharwar: KU, 1974. | Gaṅgeśa. Tattvacintāmaṇi. Hackett, 2004.

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**SANTOSH KUMAR ROY 'BATOHI'**

संतोष कुमार राय 'बटोही'

*OBC-Amat (Amatya) Satirist · Village Chronicler · Kamala-Balan Flood Reporter · Anti-Casteist Poet*

## Archive Presence & Works

Sadeha 21: Gahamā-Gahamī + Sunnara Kaniyā + Gāla Para Thappaṛa + Sāhitya Me Bhinbhiṇauja + Dalita Chī Hama + Kiṣānī + many more (pp. 1130–1148) | Sadeha 22: Kamalā-Balānak Mārala + Raudī Āora Dahāra (pp. 730–734) | Sadeha 23: Gāma (pp. 562–565) + Āuṭa Inkama (p. 995) | Sadeha 24: Gaṛabaṛajhālā (pp. 807–808) | Sadeha 25: Bakarī Saṃskṛti (pp. 62–65)

Santosh Kumar Roy 'Batohi' (pen-name Batohi — meaning 'traveller/wayfarer') is one of the most socially engaged and consistently productive writers in the Videha archive, with substantial contributions across five Sadeha volumes. His Sadeha 21 sequence is remarkable in its range: Gahamā-Gahamī (Hustle and Bustle), Sunnara Kaniyā (Beautiful Bride), Gāla Para Thappaṛa (Slap on the Cheek), Sāhitya Me Bhinbhiṇauja (The Buzzing of Flies in Literature), Dalita Chī Hama (I Am Dalit), Kiṣānī (Farming), and Binahā Byāhale Rahati Siyā (Sita Would Have Remained Unmarried). Sāhitya Me Bhinbhiṇauja is a satirical piece on literary careerists and critics — 'bhinbhiṇauja' (buzzing) suggests the noise made by self-promoters in the literary establishment. 'Dalita Chī Hama' is a direct Dalit identity assertion. Sadeha 25's Bakarī Saṃskṛti (Goat Culture) is a sustained satirical essay on the culture of docility, conformity, and following-the-herd that Roy observes in Bihar's social and political life. His Sadeha 22 reportage on the Kamala-Balan floods (Kamalā-Balānak Mārala — Killed by the Kamala-Balan Rivers) is the most direct journalistic-literary engagement with Mithila's perennial flood crisis.

## Thematic & Critical Analysis

Batohi's work embodies what the Videha Parallel History means by democratic satire. Sāhitya Me Bhinbhiṇauja directly satirises the literary establishment that the Parallel History exists to critique; Bakarī Saṃskṛti applies the same satirical lens to political culture; Gāla Para Thappaṛa (Slap on the Cheek) is a confrontational image of social assertion. 'Dalita Chī Hama' is not a lament but an identity declaration — the 'I am Dalit' statement is assertive, not apologetic. Binahā Byāhale Rahati Siyā (Sita Would Have Remained Unmarried) is a striking reinterpretation of the Ramayana: the suggestion that in contemporary conditions, even Sita — the ideal of Maithili womanhood — would not find a husband is a devastating social satire of the marriage market. The flood reportage from Kamala-Balan connects his literary practice to the journalistic tradition of Navendu Kumar Jha's reporting on the same region.

## Theoretical Frameworks

Bakhtin's carnivalesque: the 'slap on the cheek', the Bakarī Saṃskṛti satire, and the literary-establishment mockery are all carnivalesque inversions of the dignity claimed by power. Navya-Nyāya: Gaṛabaṛajhālā (Confusion/Disorder) is a title whose anumāna is implicit — hetu = observable disorder; vyāpti = disorder has causes in the social structure; sādhya = the structure needs critique. Ambedkar's Dalit assertion: 'Dalita Chī Hama' is the most Ambedkarite assertion in the Batohi corpus. The Videha Parallel History Framework: Roy's consistent presence and his direct engagement with the literary establishment's failures make him one of the Framework's most self-aware practitioners.

## Select Bibliography

Roy, Santosh Kumar 'Batohi'. Works in Videha Sadeha 21, 22, 23, 24, 25 (Prelim_21–25). ISSN 2229-547X. www.videha.co.in. | Bakhtin, M. Rabelais and His World. Tr. Iswolsky. MIT, 1968. | Ambedkar, B.R. Annihilation of Caste. Verso, 2014. | Gaṅgeśa. Tattvacintāmaṇi. Hackett, 2004.

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**SUBODH KUMAR THAKUR**

सुबोध कुमार ठाकुर

*Meditative Lyric Poet · Village Elegist · Patience as Aesthetic · Holi Poet*

## Archive Presence & Works

Sadeha 7: Viḍambanā + Pratīkṣā | Sadeha 15: Kekarā Sāṃ Kahbai (pp. 300–301) | Sadeha 33: Manaka Taraṃga + Kenā Hoeta Mithilāka Jīrṇoddhāra + Śabdaka Vāṇa + many | Sadeha 34: Āśā + Juga Badali Gela + Sunna Lāgae Gāma + Adhūrā Prema + Nenāka Praśna | Sadeha 35: Nava Varṣaka Raṃga + Prayāsa + Pratīkṣā | Sadeha 36: Ehena Jīvana Jibitaum + Hama Nai Khelab Holī (pp. 1243–1246)

Subodh Kumar Thakur has one of the most sustained and chronologically extended presences in the Videha archive, with confirmed contributions from Sadeha 7 through Sadeha 36. The pen-name Subodh (easily understood/accessible) is significant: it signals a commitment to accessible poetry rather than obscurantist literary difficulty. His recurring motif of Pratīkṣā (Waiting/Expectation) — appearing in both Sadeha 7 and Sadeha 35 — is characteristic of his meditative register. Viḍambanā (Irony/Mockery/Cruel Fate) and Pratīkṣā together establish his dominant emotional field: the irony of a world that fails its inhabitants, and the patience required to endure it. Sunna Lāgae Gāma (The Village Feels Empty/Silent) is among his most evocative titles — the silent, emptied village as the primary image of migration-era Mithila. Juga Badali Gela (The Era Has Changed) reflects on historical transformation. Hama Nai Khelab Holī (I Will Not Play Holi) is a refusal of festivity — a cultural-political statement about the conditions under which celebration is or is not appropriate.

## Thematic & Critical Analysis

Thakur's long engagement with Videha documents the trajectory of a committed Maithili poet across roughly the first two decades of the digital archive. His consistent return to the themes of waiting, emptiness, and the changed village charts the ongoing social transformation of Mithila — the village that empties as its young migrate, the era that changes regardless of one's readiness, the silence that fills the spaces where community once was. 'Hama Nai Khelab Holī' is particularly significant: the refusal to play Holi — the most communal and festive of North Indian/Maithili celebrations — is a powerful political-moral gesture, comparable to the tradition of social mourning that refuses celebration during times of injustice.

## Theoretical Frameworks

Karuṇa-rasa as primary mode: the meditative Maithili poet who witnesses village emptying and social transformation without either easy celebration or easy despair. Waiting (Pratīkṣā) as ethical posture: the repeated return to this title suggests a philosophical commitment to patience as both personal virtue and political stance. Walter Benjamin's 'On the Concept of History': the 'era has changed' reflection embeds Thakur's poetry in Benjamin's meditation on how the present is constituted by the ruins of past traditions. Navya-Nyāya: Sunna

Lāgae Gāma proceeds from a specific perceptual fact (the village is silent) through the vyāpti (silenced villages indicate absent youth) to the sādhya (the social cost of migration). The Videha Parallel History: Thakur's decades-long commitment makes him one of the archive's most durable voices.

## Select Bibliography

Thakur, Subodh Kumar. Works in Videha Sadeha 7, 15, 33, 34, 35, 36. ISSN 2229-547X. www.videha.co.in. | Benjamin, W. 'On the Concept of History.' In Illuminations. NY: Schocken, 1969. | Gaṅgeśa. Tattvacintāmaṇi. Hackett, 2004.

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**SUBODH JHA**

सुबोध झा

*Cultural Essayist · Folk-Literary Voice · Śāirī Practitioner*

## Archive Presence & Works

Sadeha 7 (Prelim_7): Batahiyā + Śāirī 1–5 + Manabatiyā + Saṃskṛti O Saṃskāra + Jīnagī

Subodh Jha appears in Sadeha 7 with a distinctive combination of forms: Batahiyā (the wandering/confused/slightly mad person — also a Maithili folk character type), Śāirī 1–5 (five śāirī — the Urdu/Hindi term for verses/couplets, related to but distinct from formal ghazal), Manabatiyā (Heart's Candle/Lamp — from mana/heart + batī/lamp or wick), Saṃskṛti O Saṃskāra (Culture and Cultural Values/Impressions), and Jīnagī (Life — the Maithili form of the Hindi zindagī). The inclusion of the 'Batahiyā' character is culturally significant: the batahiyā is a folk figure of Mithila — the person who has lost their way (literally or mentally), who speaks in fragments, who exists at the margins of social order. This figure carries both pathos and comic possibility.

## Thematic & Critical Analysis

The combination of Saṃskṛti O Saṃskāra (an analytical essay on culture and cultural formation) with Batahiyā (the folk marginal figure) and Śāirī (the semi-formal verse tradition) in a single contribution creates a rich generic mix. Subodh Jha's essay on Saṃskṛti O Saṃskāra would be a reflection on the relationship between Maithili cultural inheritance (saṃskṛti — the accumulated cultural tradition) and the personal-social formation it produces (saṃskāra — both ritual rites of passage and the mental/moral impressions formed by cultural conditioning). Manabatiyā (Heart's Candle) is an image of the private inner light that is both vulnerable (a candle can be extinguished) and persistent (it continues to illuminate despite the darkness). The śāirī form — five short verse-couplets — is the everyday lyric tradition of Maithili-Hindi culture, closely related to the folk proverb and the sung verse.

## Theoretical Frameworks

The Batahiyā figure in relation to Foucault's concept of madness (Madness and Civilization, 1961): the mad/wandering figure as the one who sees social reality from outside its normative framework. Kuntaka's vakrokti: the śāirī form is vakrokti at the level of social interaction — the oblique, indirect speech of everyday life elevated to a literary practice. Navya-Nyāya and saṃskāra: Gaṅgeśa's analysis of saṃskāra (mental trace/impression) as a category of epistemology — the stored impressions from previous perceptions — resonates with Jha's essay topic: how cultural formation (saṃskāra) shapes present cognition and social behaviour. The Videha Parallel History: Jha's inclusion of the Batahiyā folk type alongside formal cultural analysis enacts the Framework's commitment to the full range of Maithili cultural expression.

## Select Bibliography

Jha, Subodh. Batahiyā et al. Videha Sadeha 7 (Prelim_7). ISSN 2229-547X. www.videha.co.in. | Foucault, M. Madness and Civilization. Tr. Howard. NY: Vintage, 1988. | Kuntaka. Vakroktijīvita. KU, 1977. | Gaṅgeśa. Tattvacintāmaṇi. Hackett, 2004.

**SUBHASH KUMAR KAMAT**

सुभाष कुमार कामत

*Bīhani Kathā Satirist · Labour Rights Voice · Corporate-Critique Writer*

## Archive Presence & Works

Sadeha 23 (Prelim_23): Bīhani Kathā — Tanakhāha / Bhūkha / Buṛhavā Peṃśana / Maithilī / Auṃṭhā / Munāphā (6 stories) | Sadeha 24 (Prelim_24): Aspatāla + Raṃga + Cākolēṭa + Nūna + Ānalāīna (5 stories)

Subhash Kumar Kamat is a distinctive voice in the Videha bīhani kathā tradition, with eleven documented short fiction pieces across two Sadeha volumes whose titles form a remarkable social lexicon of contemporary economic life: Tanakhāha (Salary), Bhūkha (Hunger), Buṛhavā Peṃśana (Old Man's Pension), Maithilī (the language itself as subject), Auṃṭhā (Thumb — as in the thumb-impression of the illiterate, or the thumb that scrolls through a smartphone), Munāphā (Profit). Sadeha 24 continues: Aspatāla (Hospital), Raṃga (Colour), Cākolēṭa (Chocolate), Nūna (Salt), Ānalāīna (Online). This is a pointed social vocabulary: from salary to hunger to old-age pension to the language itself as a precarious object, to the hospital, chocolate, and online connectivity — the journey through Kamat's bīhani kathā titles is a journey through contemporary Bihar's economic landscape, from the rural poor (hunger, pension, thumb-impression) to the urban-aspirant (chocolate, online). The title 'Maithilī' — naming the language itself as the subject of a bīhani kathā — suggests a story about the language's precarious situation: the threat to Maithili's survival as a living language in the era of Hindi and English dominance.

## Thematic & Critical Analysis

Kamat's most striking contribution is the use of 'Maithilī' as a bīhani kathā title: the language itself as a character, subject, or situation in a very short story. This is the Videha Parallel History's meta-literary moment — the language that the archive exists to sustain becomes the subject of one of its contributions. The economic lexicon of his bīhani kathā (salary, hunger, pension, profit, hospital, online) maps the specific economic anxieties of Bihar's transitional society: the formal sector worker anxious about salary, the rural poor facing hunger, the

elderly dependent on an inadequate pension system, the emerging middle class accessing chocolate and the internet. 'Nūna' (Salt) evokes Gandhi's Dandi March — salt as the most basic necessity and the most potent symbol of economic exploitation.

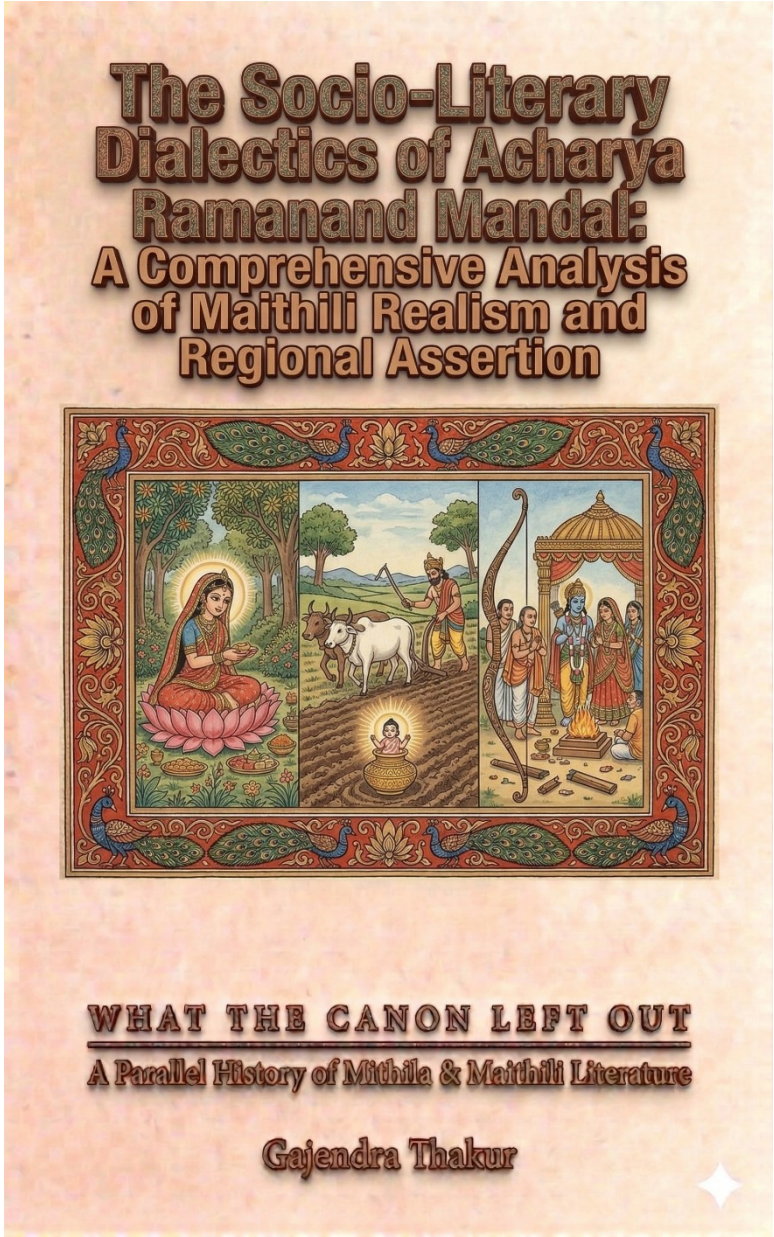
## Theoretical Frameworks

Brecht's Verfremdungseffekt: the bīhani kathā's compression creates estrangement — familiar economic realities (salary, pension) are made strange by being placed in a literary frame that demands reflection. The title 'Maithilī' as bīhani kathā subject: intertextual resonance with the Parallel History's entire archival project — what happens to a language when it is treated as a story rather than as a living medium? Navya-Nyāya anumāna: the sequence from Tanakhāha to Bhūkha to Buṛhavā Peṃśana follows an inferential chain — salary insufficient, therefore hunger, therefore inadequate pension. The Videha Parallel History: Kamat's meta-linguistic story 'Maithilī' may be the archive's most self-aware single contribution.

## Select Bibliography

Kamat, Subhash Kumar. Works in Videha Sadeha 23, 24 (Prelim_23–24). ISSN 2229-547X. www.videha.co.in. | Brecht, B. Brecht on Theatre. Tr. Willett. NY: Hill & Wang, 1964. | Gaṅgeśa. Tattvacintāmaṇi. Hackett, 2004.

**LESSON 063 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**



# ACHARYA RAMANAND MANDAL

*A Complete Critical Research Report*

Analysed Through Indian & Western Literary Theories,

the Videha Parallel History Framework,

and Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya

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**Works Examined:**

*Bhāsā Ke Na Bāṃṭiyo (भासा के न बांटियो, 2022) — Poetry Collection in Western Maithili (Bajjika)*

*Rāṇiyāṃ Bhikhārin (रनियां भिखारिन, 2023) — Short Story Collection in Western Maithili*

*Gāgar Meṃ Sāgar: Nava Vaicārikī (गागर में सागर, 2025) — Essays/Socio-critical Articles*

## 1. Biographical Profile and Intellectual Formation

Acharya Ramanand Mandal (born 1960, Sitamarhi, Bihar) is a retired schoolteacher-turned-writer who emerged as a significant literary voice in Maithili literature following his retirement from government service on 31 December 2019. A postgraduate in Chemistry (M.Sc.) and Hindi Literature from a Maithili-speaking background, he served as Headmaster in middle schools of Sitamarhi district before devoting himself fully to literature. He writes under the abbreviated name 'Rāmā' in his poetry.

His intellectual formation was shaped by three converging forces: (a) the Sitamarhi-Mithila civilisational milieu — the birthplace of Sita and a zone where Western Maithili (Bajjika) is the vernacular; (b) exposure to social media activism around Maithili language rights, where encounters with Kishun Karigar, Ramnaresh Yadav, Dr. Umesh Mandal, Kaviraj Ekaant, and others crystallised his literary voice; and (c) the persistent encouragement of his eldest son, Prof. (Dr.) Rajiv Ranjan, an academic who urged him to write. His scientific temperament — a rationalised, empirical worldview — infuses his literary production with an unmistakable logical sharpness.

Mandal's published works to date are three: a poetry collection in Western Maithili/Bajjika (2022), a short story collection in the same dialect (2023), and a collection of socio-critical essays in Hindi-inflected Maithili (2025), all published by Mithila Samaj Trust, Delhi. The essays in Gāgar Meṃ Sāgar were composed after active participation in the Sagar Rāti Dīp Jaray (108th–112th) literary evenings, earning praise from Sahitya Akademi awardee Jagdish Prasad Mandal, senior critic Dr. Ramanand Jha 'Raman', and senior reviewer Taranand Viyogi. *Gāgar Meṃ Sāgar was published by Book Fylo.*

## 2. The Three Works: Synoptic Description

### 2.1 Bhāsā Ke Na Bāṃṭiyo (2022) — Poetry Collection

This debut collection of 87 poems is written in Western Maithili (Bajjika), the dialect spoken in the Sitamarhi-Muzaffarpur belt. The title poem, 'Bhāsā Ke Na Bāṃṭiyo' ('Do Not Divide the Language'), is both an aesthetic manifesto and a socio-political protest — a passionate plea against fracturing the Maithili linguistic continuum by treating Bajjika, Angika, and standard Maithili as separate languages.

The collection is organised around six thematic axes: (i) identity and language rights; (ii) Mithila's mythological-historical heritage (Sita, Vidyapati, Loriqa, Dinakar, Phaniswarnath Renu); (iii) social critique (caste hierarchy, varna system, patriarchy); (iv) political satire (panchayat corruption, opportunist state-making); (v) devotional and folk themes (Chhath, Jhijhiya, Dadhichi); and (vi) personal-humanist reflections (mother, wife, death, seasons).

**Selected key poems:** *'Jīvan Ke Raṇkṣetra Meṃ'* (existentialist opener); *'Hum Kabīr Banabaī'* (Bhakti invocation — self-identification with Kabir's dissent); *'Avīr Sītā'* (feminist rewriting of Sita's exile); *'Bhūmijā Sītā'* (earth-daughter Sita as postcolonial subaltern heroine); *'Śahīd Rāmaphal Maṇḍal'* (tribute to freedom fighter); *'Chhath'*, *'Jhaajhaa Mel'* (folk satirical); *'Nārī Tū Ke Chhe?'* (interrogative feminist poem); *'Angikā Bajjikā'* (linguistic solidarity anthem).

### 2.2 Rāṇiyāṃ Bhikhārin (2023) — Short Story Collection

This collection of 28 stories in Western Maithili is Mandal's second published work, dedicated to his mother Chandra Devi. The stories range from 3 to 14 pages and are drawn from observed life in villages of north Bihar — exploring

love (licit and illicit), social inequality, generational conflict, political corruption, religious hypocrisy, unemployment, and existential ethics.

The title story, 'Rāṇiyāṃ Bhikhārin', is Mandal's most discussed piece: a polio-afflicted twenty-five-year-old woman who begs near a bus stand is sexually exploited by the conductor and gives birth to a child whom she nurtures with absolute maternal devotion — transcending categories of legitimate/illegitimate, consent/exploitation, purity/transgression. The story is simultaneously a social-realist document and a metaphysical meditation on vatsalya (parental love) as the most primal human capacity.

Other notable stories: 'Ādarśa Putra' (ideal son vs. NRI son — a study in duty and abandonment); 'Sādā Jīvan Uchcha Vicār' (a Muslim schoolteacher's dignified simplicity as an ethical ideal); 'Dharam Saṃkaṭ Mukta' (feudal erotics, caste transgression, desire); 'Kāma Se Rāma Ke Or' (Rajneesh's philosophy embedded in a village romance); 'Rakt Sambandh' (blood-kinship vs. adoptive kinship); 'Maithilī' (mother tongue as intimate dialogue).

## 2.3 Gāgar Meṃ Sāgar: Nava Vaicārikī (2025) — Essay Collection

The title — 'An Ocean in a Pot: A New Thinking' — announces the epistemological ambition of this essay collection. Written largely in Hindi-blended Maithili prose, it covers historical, socio-cultural, linguistic, and biographical topics. Key essays include:

- 'Babuavādī Saṃskṛti Banam Hāśiye kā Samāj' — Brahmanical hegemony in Mithila, citing George Grierson's Linguistic Survey of India and local caste dynamics.
- 'Kavīśvara Candā Jhā vs. George Grierson' — a revisionary account of the making of Maithili as a named language.
- 'Maithilī Mānakaraṇ' — critique of standardisation that excludes Bajjika/Angika speakers.
- 'Mithilā Rāja vs. Tirhut' — geographical-political critique of the proposed Mithila state.
- 'Magadh vs. Mithilā' — historiographical debate on the two civilisational poles of Bihar.
- 'Śahīd Rāmaphal Maṇḍal' — biography of Mithila's first freedom martyr.
- 'Phaniswarnath Renu', 'Kapūrī Ṭhākur', 'Gajendr Ṭhākur' — biographical sketches of Maithili icons.

## 3. The Question of Language: Bajjika, Maithili, and the Dialectal Continuum

Mandal's most foundational literary-political stance is the insistence that Bajjika (Western Maithili, spoken in Sitamarhi, Muzaffarpur, Vaishali, Sheohar, East Champaran) is not a separate language but a dialect of Maithili. This is simultaneously a linguistic, social, and legal argument. In 'Bhāsā Ke Na Bāṃṭiyo' the poet writes:

> *'Bajjikā Anjgikā / Alag Bhāṣā Nahy / Maithilī Ke Boli Sab' — All are dialects of Maithili, not separate languages.*

The Mithila Samaj Trust's publication foreword (Book 1) contextualises this precisely: just as Kannada, Bengali, and Punjabi embrace all their dialects within their literary mainstream, Maithili must do so, and the obsession with a Sanskritic 'standard' Maithili risks killing the oral vitality of the language. This echoes Grierson's original observation in the Linguistic Survey of India (1881–1928) that Western Maithili forms a regional variation with phonological divergences but continuous with the Maithili linguistic core.

The Videha Parallel History Framework (Gajendra Thakur, videha.co.in) has consistently argued that mainstream Maithili literary history, as promoted by the Sahitya Akademi advisory board, represents only the Brahmin-Kayasth 'sotipur' Maithili of Darbhanga-Madhubani, excluding Bajjika, Angika, Khorthā, and Surajapuri speakers. Mandal's work is thus organically connected to the Videha movement's project of literary democratisation.

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## 4. Situating Mandal Within the Videha Parallel History Framework

### 4.1 The Videha Framework: A Summary

The Videha eJournal (ISSN 2229-547X, www.videha.co.in), founded and edited by Gajendra Thakur, has since 2000 built what it calls a 'Parallel History of Mithila and Maithili Literature' — a historiographical project that recovers the literary output of non-Brahmin, Dalit, lower-OBC, and dialectal writers systematically ignored by the Sahitya Akademi advisory board and its allied 'mainstream' literary organisations. The framework draws on the Dooshan Panji (genealogical records of social infractions), oral histories, and non-canonical sources to contest the hegemonic narrative.

T.K. Oomen's sociological observation (Sociology, 1988) that 'the Maithili region is economically and culturally dominated by Brahmins' and that a Maithili state might entrench them further as political elite — an observation cited in the Videha Parallel History — provides the larger social context. The Videha framework's critical insight is that Maithili literary canonisation has functioned as a 'sieve' that filters out non-elite voices, regardless of literary merit.

### 4.2 Mandal's Place in the Parallel Tradition

Mandal exemplifies the parallel literary tradition on at least four dimensions:

- Dialectal authenticity: Writing in Bajjika rather than 'standard' Maithili is itself a political act within the Videha framework — it reclaims the language from its Sanskritic standardisers.
- Social subject matter: Dalit characters (Raniyaan, Kosaliya), agricultural labourers, OBC youth unemployment, feudal landlord-serf dynamics, and inter-caste desire are all marginalised in mainstream Maithili literature but central to Mandal's fiction.
- Counter-hagiography: In Gāgar Meṃ Sāgar, Mandal writes biographies of Shahid Ramaphal Mandal (the first Mithila freedom fighter, largely unknown even in Mithila), Gajendra Thakur, and Phaniswarnath Renu — figures who represent either OBC/Mandal communities or counter-canonical streams.
- Publishing ecology: Publication by Mithila Samaj Trust (a non-Brahmin cultural institution) rather than Sahitya Akademi or Darbhanga-based presses situates Mandal within the parallel institutional network.

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## 5. Applying Navya-Nyāya Epistemology to Mandal's Works

### 5.1 Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya and the Tattvacintāmaṇi

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (c. 1300–1350 CE), born in Mithila, authored the Tattvacintāmaṇi ('Thought-Jewel of Truth'), which inaugurated the Navya-Nyāya school of Indian logic. As documented extensively in Videha Parallel History Parts 16–20 and in Dinesh Chandra Bhattacharya's History of Navya-Nyāya in Mithila, Gaṅgeśa revolutionised Indian epistemology by shifting

from broad ontological (prameya) analysis to hyper-precise epistemological (pramāṇa) inquiry.

The Navya-Nyāya analytical toolkit includes: (a) Pramāṇa (valid means of knowledge); (b) Vyāpti (invariable concomitance); (c) Avacchedaka ('limitor' — a precision operator to prevent ambiguity); (d) Hetvābhāsa (logical fallacies); (e) Paratah Pramāṇya (extrinsic validity of knowledge — knowledge is validated through successful practical action); and (f) the fourfold division of Pramāṇas: Pratyakṣa (perception), Anumāna (inference), Upamāna (analogy), Śabda (verbal testimony).

The Videha Parallel History also recovers a suppressed biographical fact: Gaṅgeśa was born five years after the death of his recognised father and married a Charmkarini (a woman from the leather-working community). This makes him — like Mandal — a figure whose intellectual achievement transcended social marginalisation.

## 5.2 Navya-Nyāya Applied: Poetry (Bhāsā Ke Na Bāṃṭiyo)

### *5.2.1 Pramāṇa and the Validity of the Dialectal Voice*

In Navya-Nyāya, knowledge is validated not intrinsically (the Mīmāṃsā position) but through practical success — 'Paratah Pramāṇya'. Mandal's use of Bajjika as a literary medium is precisely such a Paratah Pramāṇya: its legitimacy is not declared a priori by any academy but demonstrated through its communicative effectiveness, emotional resonance, and the social recognition it generates. The success of Book 1 — reaching even to the Deputy Chief Minister's hands, as noted in the Book 2 foreword — is, in Navya-Nyāya terms, the 'samvādipravṛtti' (successful purposive activity) that validates the cognition.

### *5.2.2 Vyāpti (Invariable Concomitance) in the Title Poem*

Gaṅgeśa defines Vyāpti as the invariable co-presence of the middle term (Hetu) and the major term (Sādhya). In 'Bhāsā Ke Na Bāṃṭiyo', the logical structure can be formalised thus:

> *Wherever there is language fragmentation (Hetu), there is cultural impoverishment and political subjugation (Sādhya). Bajjika is subject to language fragmentation. Therefore, Bajjika speakers face cultural impoverishment and political subjugation.*

The poem's rhetorical power lies in this vyāpti being established not abstractly but through concrete historical evidence — the fate of Angika writers whose works were rejected by Maithili literary bodies because their dialect was not 'standard' Maithili.

### *5.2.3 Avacchedaka (Limitor) and Poetic Precision*

Gaṅgeśa's avacchedaka prevents infinite regress in predication by specifying the 'conditioner' of a property. Mandal's best poems operate with similar precision. In 'Avīr Sītā', the limitor is gender (strītvāvacchinna — 'conditioned by femininity') rather than divinity or royalty — Sita is analysed through the property 'abandoned woman' (parityaktatvāvacchinna), which generates the poem's ironic reversal: the 'hero' Rama becomes the 'deserter' and the 'weak' (avīra) Sita becomes the 'courageous' (vīra).

### *5.2.4 Hetvābhāsa (Fallacy Analysis) in Political Satire*

Several of Mandal's satirical poems ('Mithilā Rāj Banā Dā', 'Pañcāyat Cunāv', 'Rāj Karaī Chī') expose what Navya-Nyāya calls Savyabhicāra (deviating reason — the middle term does not always accompany the major term) and Viruddha (contradictory reason). Mandal's satire of Mithila state-hood demands shows politicians who claim cultural identity (Hetu) while pursuing caste patronage (Sādhya) — but cultural identity does not invariably lead to the Sādhya (welfare of all Maithils), so the Hetu is a Savyabhicāra fallacy.

## 5.3 Navya-Nyāya Applied: Stories (Rāṇiyāṃ Bhikhārin)

### *5.3.1 Śabda-Khaṇḍa and the Story 'Maithilī'*

In Gaṅgeśa's Śabda-Khaṇḍa, valid verbal testimony requires four conditions: Ākāṅkṣā (syntactic expectancy), Yogyatā (semantic fitness), Sannidhi (temporal proximity), and Tātparya (speaker's intention). The story 'Maithilī' is formally a dialogue about mother tongue — a wife initially dismisses the language as irrelevant but gradually discovers its beauty, utility, and identity-forming power. Applying Śabda criteria: the wife's initial dismissal ('Maithilī is not our language') fails Yogyatā — it is semantically incoherent because she herself speaks Maithili. Mandal thus dramatises epistemological error through narrative.

### *5.3.2 Pratyakṣa and Anumāna in 'Dharam Saṃkaṭ Mukta'*

Gaṅgeśa distinguishes Nirvikalpaka (raw, pre-linguistic perception) from Savikalpaka (relational, linguistically structured perception). In this story, Rajeshwar Pratap's initial perception of Raniyan is Nirvikalpaka — pure visual apprehension without the caste-qualifier. His attraction grows into Savikalpaka cognition only when he applies the caste-limitor (dalitatvāvacchinna) — and at that point social conflict begins. Mandal shows how social consciousness corrupts raw perceptual purity, a point that resonates with both Navya-Nyāya epistemology and Dalit literary theory.

### *5.3.3 The Title Story: Upamāna (Analogy) and Vātsalya*

Gaṅgeśa's Upamāna-Khaṇḍa defends analogy as an independent pramāṇa. In 'Rāṇiyāṃ Bhikhārin', Mandal invites a moral analogy: Raniyan's relation to her child is analogous (upamāna) to Yashoda's relation to Krishna — the divine model of vātsalya that transcends birth-circumstances. This upamāna is not ornamental but epistemological: it generates valid moral knowledge ('maternal love transcends social stigma') that cannot be derived by perception (pratyakṣa) alone.

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# 6. Western Literary Critical Frameworks

## 6.1 Mikhail Bakhtin: Heteroglossia and the Dialogic Novel

Mikhail Bakhtin's concept of heteroglossia — the coexistence of multiple social voices and registers within a single text (The Dialogic Imagination, 1981) — is the single most productive Western framework for Mandal's fiction. His stories are aggressively dialogic: 'Maithilī' is literally a dialogue between two registers of identity; 'Ādarśa Putra' sets village dutiful-son dialect against NRI-English phone discourse; 'Sādā Jīvan Uchcha Vicār' places Hindi-Urdu school administration language against Maithili community speech.

More deeply, Bakhtin's carnivalesque — the temporary inversion of social hierarchies — operates in 'Rāṇiyāṃ Bhikhārin' where a marginalised, disabled beggar-woman becomes the moral centre of the narrative, while the 'respectable' conductor is its moral nadir.

## 6.2 Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak: Can the Subaltern Speak?

Spivak's foundational question in postcolonial theory ('Can the Subaltern Speak?' 1988) finds a nuanced, affirmative answer in Mandal's project. His subalterns — Raniyan, the leather-worker woman, the unemployed OBC youth in 'Garib Ke Kahāṃ Guzārā Na' — do speak, but in a dialect that the standard literary establishment refuses to hear. The linguistic politics of Bajjika vs. standard Maithili is thus a literalisation of Spivak's epistemological argument about whose speech counts as 'literature'.

Mandal's essay 'Babuavādī Saṃskṛti Banam Hāśiye kā Samāj' makes this Spivakian argument explicitly, citing the Bajjika writer who brought her manuscript to the Maithili Sahitya Akademi only to be told it was 'not Maithili'. This is the institutional silencing of the subaltern voice.

## 6.3 Antonio Gramsci: Hegemony and the Organic Intellectual

Gramsci's distinction between the 'traditional intellectual' (who reproduces ruling-class ideology) and the 'organic intellectual' (who emerges from and serves a subaltern class, Prison Notebooks 1929–35) maps precisely onto the contrast between the Brahmin-Kayasth Maithili literary establishment and Mandal. Mandal is what Gramsci calls an organic intellectual of the Mandal community (OBC Backward Classes) — not by proclamation but by the logic of his subject matter, his dialect choice, his publishing ecology, and his political commitments.

## 6.4 Terry Eagleton: Literature as Ideology

Terry Eagleton's materialist critique (Criticism and Ideology, 1976; Literary Theory: An Introduction, 1983) argues that literary form is not neutral but ideologically overdetermined. Mandal's choice of Bajjika is not merely aesthetic; it is an ideological choice that challenges the hegemony of Sanskritic standard Maithili. The form of his poetry — direct, oral, repetitive, close to speech-rhythm — is itself a critique of the elite courtly forms (Vidyapati-influenced padāvalī metres) that dominate 'official' Maithili literature.

## 6.5 Northrop Frye: Archetypal Criticism

Frye's theory of archetypes (Anatomy of Criticism, 1957) illuminates Mandal's mythological poems. 'Bhūmijā Sītā' and 'Avīr Sītā' recast the Sita archetype from the Demeter-Persephone pattern (fertility-abduction-return) into a tragic-ironic pattern where the return is denied by the same hero who promised it.

'Hum Kabīr Banabaī' invokes the Trickster-Sage archetype — Kabir as the outsider-truth-teller who disrupts sacred orders. Frye's seasonal myth of Autumn (decline, satire, irony) pervades the political poems.

### 6.6 Sigmund Freud and Jacques Lacan: Desire, the Gaze, and the Other

In 'Dharam Saṃkaṭ Mukta', the feudal landlord's desire for the Dalit woman follows a Lacanian logic: Raniyan is positioned as the objet petit a — the object-cause of desire that the subject (Rajeshwar Pratap) can never fully possess, because possession would dissolve the social distance that constitutes the desire itself. The story's tragic arc — where love becomes exploitation — traces the Lacanian transition from the Imaginary register (pure desire, Nirvikalpaka perception) to the Symbolic register (caste-coded social law) that destroys it.

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## 7. Indian Literary Critical Frameworks

### 7.1 Rasa Theory (Bharata, Abhinavagupta)

Bharata's Nāṭyaśāstra (c. 200 BCE – 200 CE) posits eight (later nine) fundamental aesthetic emotions (rasas) that literature evokes. Abhinavagupta's Abhinavabhāratī commentary (c. 1000 CE) develops the concept of rasa as aesthetic consciousness (rasāsvādana) transcending ordinary emotion. Mandal's work invites analysis across the full rasa spectrum:

| Rasa | Text / Poem / Story | Manifestation |
|---|---|---|
| Śṛṅgāra (love) | *'Pārō', 'Gauri', 'Prem Ke Jīt'* | Consensual romantic love across class lines |
| Karuṇā (compassion) | *'Rāṇiyāṃ Bhikhārin', 'Vidhavā'* | Compassion for the exploited, the widowed, the disabled |
| Vīra (heroism) | *'Śahīd Rāmaphal Maṇḍal', 'Vīr Loriqa'* | Celebration of subaltern heroism |
| Raudra (fury) | *'Jātivāda', 'Bābū', 'Dhut Buṛbak'* | Moral rage against casteism and hypocrisy |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| Hāsya (satire) | *'Jhājhā Mel', 'Pañcāyat Cunāv'* | Satirical laughter at village corruption |
| Bībhatsa (disgust) | *'Kharabs', 'Śarāb aur Śabāb'* | Revulsion at social exploitation |
| Śānta (serenity) | *'Sādā Jīvan Uchcha Vicār', 'Mahāyajña'* | Meditative acceptance and ethical clarity |
| Adbhuta (wonder) | *'Bhūmijā Sītā', 'Buddha'* | Wonder at the sacred in the everyday |

The dominant rasa of the collection as a whole is Karuṇā with Raudra as its tonal companion — a compassionate fury that is the hallmark of socially engaged literature. Abhinavagupta's concept of sādhāraṇīkaraṇa (universalisation of emotion) is relevant: Mandal achieves this through placing universal archetypes (Sita, Kabir, Buddha) in recognisably local Maithili situations.

## 7.2 Dhvani Theory (Ānandavardhana)

Ānandavardhana's Dhvanyāloka (c. 850 CE) proposes that the highest literary meaning is not the expressed (vācya) but the suggested (vyañjanā) or resonant (dhvani) meaning. Mandal's best poems operate through dhvani of the Rasadhvani type — suggested emotional meaning.

In 'Bhāsā Ke Na Bāṃṭiyo' (the title poem), the expressed meaning is a plea against linguistic division. The suggested meaning — dhvani — is that the division of the language is the last step in the erasure of the non-elite Maithili subject: when your dialect is not recognised as 'your language', you lose legal, educational, and political rights. This second-order dhvani is what gives the poem its electrifying political charge beyond its apparent linguistic subject.

## 7.3 Vakrokti Theory (Kuntaka)

Kuntaka's Vakroktijīvita (c. 950 CE) argues that the essence of poetry is 'oblique expression' (vakrokti) — the deviation of speech from its ordinary form that produces aesthetic pleasure. Mandal's Bajjika idiom is itself a form of vakrokti relative to the standard Maithili literary register: by choosing the 'oblique' dialect, Mandal defamiliarises the Maithili text, making the reader experience the language freshly rather than through the habituation of standard

forms. This connects to Russian Formalist ostranenie (defamiliarisation), demonstrating the Indo-European convergence of poetic theory.

### 7.4 Dalit Aesthetics and Ambedkarian Literary Criticism

Contemporary Indian Dalit literary criticism, rooted in B.R. Ambedkar's foundational critique of Brahminical cultural hegemony (Annihilation of Caste, 1936), has developed an autonomous aesthetic: the primacy of lived social experience over inherited literary convention; the rejection of 'universal' aesthetics that invisibilise caste oppression; the affirmation of vernacular, dialect, and oral traditions as sites of resistance.

Mandal's work engages this framework most directly in 'Rāṇiyāṃ Bhikhārin' (the title story), 'Dharam Saṃkaṭ Mukta', 'Kharabs' and 'Gāgar Meṃ Sāgar' (Brahminvāda essay). His Dalit characters are not passive victims but active agents who make moral choices — the Dalit aesthetic criterion of 'dignity in adversity'. The Videha Parallel History's inclusion of Dalit Telugu, Gujarati, and Odia literature in Maithili translation (Parts 11–15) provides the larger frame within which Mandal's fiction is a Bihar-specific contribution.

### 7.5 Sāhitya-Darpaṇa (Viśvanātha Kavirāja) and Narrative Theory

Viśvanātha Kavirāja's Sāhitya-Darpaṇa (c. 1335 CE) defines kāvya (literature) as 'vākya rasamātmakam' — utterance whose soul is rasa. His prose narrative theory (ākhyāyikā vs. kathā distinction) is relevant to Mandal's stories. Mandal's stories are closer to the kathā form — fictional, multi-episodic, with the narrator distanced from events — except for the memoir-inflected stories ('Sādā Jīvan Uchcha Vicār', 'Mithilā') where the author enters as a first-person narrator (dāyanand), approximating the ākhyāyikā form.

## 8. Cross-Thematic Critical Analysis

### 8.1 Language as Political Subject

Across all three books, language — specifically the right to write in one's own dialect — is the master theme. This is unusual: most writers treat language as medium, not subject. For Mandal, the act of writing Bajjika is simultaneously the message and the medium. This recursive self-reflexivity — writing about

language politics in the language whose politics one is defending — constitutes what the Russian Formalists would call a 'laying bare of the device'.

## 8.2 The Sita Motif: Feminist Revisionism

The figure of Sita recurs across all three books: as the abandoned heroine in poetry ('Avīr Sītā', 'Bhūmijā Sītā'), as the geographical anchor of Sitamarhi identity (narrative preamble of 'Maithilī'), and as the mythological legitimator of Mithila's claim to distinctiveness (essay on Mithila vs. Tirhut). Mandal's Sita is consistently rescued from passive victimhood: 'Nirjāsit bhel avīr Sītā, vīr Sītā banal avīr Sītā' — the apparently powerless Sita is redefined as the truly powerful one.

This feminist revisionism connects to the Videha framework's sustained attention to women's writing (Strī Konā section of Videha) and to the Indian feminist critical tradition represented by scholars like Susie Tharu and K. Lalita (Women Writing in India, 1991).

## 8.3 Scientific Rationalism as Literary Method

Mandal's M.Sc. in Chemistry is not incidental to his literary method. The preface to Book 2 (Rāṇiyāṃ Bhikhārin) notes that 'his scientific temperament, logic, and rationalist worldview are inevitably visible in his compositions'. This is borne out in: (a) the essayistic prose of Gāgar Meṃ Sāgar, which deploys statistical data (UNESCO's 8,324 languages, India's 1,635 mother tongues), historical chronology, and causal analysis; (b) the logical precision of the title poem's argument; (c) the refusal of supernatural or mystical explanation in his stories of desire and transgression.

In Navya-Nyāya terms, this is a commitment to Pramāṇa — valid means of knowledge — over mere convention or scriptural authority (āgama). Mandal implicitly aligns himself with Gaṅgeśa's rationalist, evidence-based epistemology rather than the Mīmāṃsā reliance on scriptural self-validity (svataḥ prāmāṇya).

## 8.4 Subaltern Heroism: Shahid Ramaphal Mandal

The repeated invocation of Shahid Ramaphal Mandal — Mithila's first freedom martyr, largely absent from mainstream Mithila historiography — is the biographical correlate of the poetic-fictional project. Just as Gaṅgeśa's low-caste birth was suppressed in official Mithila intellectual history (Videha Parallel History, Part 16), Ramaphal Mandal's martyrdom was suppressed

because it represented subaltern nationalism rather than Brahmin-led nationalist movement. For Mandal, recovering these suppressed lives is itself a literary-epistemological act: it is the application of anumāna (inference from available evidence) against the hetvābhāsa (fallacious reasoning) of official historiography.

## 9. Critical Appreciation: Strengths, Complexities, and Limitations

### 9.1 Strengths

- Linguistic courage: Writing seriously in Bajjika when the entire literary establishment devalues it is an act of aesthetic and political courage. Mandal has essentially created a modern literary Bajjika where none previously existed in published form.
- Thematic breadth: The range from linguistic philosophy to Dalit women's dignity to Sufi/Rajneesh-inflected spirituality to climate of panchayat corruption is remarkable for a debut corpus.
- Narrative intimacy: Mandal's stories achieve what Henry James called the 'felt life' of fiction — the characters speak, argue, desire, and fail in recognisably human ways, anchored in the specific ecology of north Bihar.
- Essayistic rigour: Gāgar Meṃ Sāgar's essays combine local knowledge with broader historiographical frameworks (Grierson, Oomen) in a way that is rare in regional Indian essay writing.
- Internal coherence: The three books form a triptych — the poetry establishes the political identity; the fiction enacts it through lives; the essays theorise it.

### 9.2 Areas of Critical Complexity

- Tonal unevenness: Some poems in Book 1 are direct to the point of being polemical rather than poetic — the political argument is stated rather than enacted through image or metaphor. The best poems ('Avīr Sītā', 'Bhūmijā Sītā', 'Hum Kabīr Banabaī') are far superior to the more didactic pieces.
- Narrative compression: Several stories in Rāṇiyāṃ Bhikhārin are compressed to the point where character development suffers — the reader intuits rather than experiences the emotional arc. This is partly a function of

the short-story form but also of Mandal's greater comfort with the essay and poem.

- Dialectal accessibility: Writing in Bajjika restricts the immediate readership, though this is precisely the point. A future scholarly apparatus (glossary, transliterations) would greatly expand critical engagement.
- Historical documentation: The biographical essays in Gāgar Meṃ Sāgar would benefit from more systematic citation of sources, making them more useful to future historians.

### 9.3 A Note on the Gangesha–Mandal Parallelism

Notably, a structural parallelism between Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya and Acharya Ramanand Mandal that the Videha Parallel History framework makes visible. Both are Mithila-born thinkers of non-elite social background who produce foundational intellectual work in registers not recognised as 'canonical' by the Brahminical establishment of their time. Gaṅgeśa's marriage to a Charmkarini and extra-matrimonial birth were suppressed for centuries; Mandal's Bajjika is dismissed by the Sanskritic literary gatekeepers. Both, in Navya-Nyāya terms, have achieved Paratah Pramāṇya — the validation of their knowledge through practical success — despite institutional resistance.

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*Research prepared with reference to: (i) the three published works of Acharya Ramanand Mandal(iii) established scholarship on Indian and Western literary theory.*

*2*

**The Socio-Literary Dialectics of Acharya Ramanand Mandal: A Comprehensive Analysis of Maithili Realism and Regional Assertion**

**The trajectory of Maithili literature in the twenty-first century is defined by a rigorous departure from the courtly and classical traditions that long dominated the Mithila region. At the center of this modernizing shift is Acharya Ramanand Mandal, a retired headmaster, social thinker, and literary figure whose work serves as a conduit for the "pure Maithili" spoken in Sitamarhi, the historically and mythologically significant birthplace of Goddess Sita. Within the framework of the *Videha* e-journal and the broader movement of Maithili digital journalism, Mandal’s**

**narratives function as sociological inquiries into the decay of institutional integrity, the persistence of caste hierarchies, and the transformative potential of education within subaltern communities.**

**Historical Context and the Emergence of the Parallel Tradition**

**To understand the significance of Acharya Ramanand Mandal, one must first locate his work within the evolving landscape of Maithili literary recognition and institutional politics. The recognition of Maithili by the Sahitya Akademi in 1965 was a watershed moment, yet it was fraught with internal tensions between the traditionalist elite and the burgeoning reformist voices. For decades, the Maithili literary canon was heavily influenced by the Darbhanga-centric "standard," which often prioritized the linguistic registers of the *Srotriya* Brahmins and the genealogical focus of *Panji-Prabandha*.**

**Mandal represents a shift toward a more inclusive "Parallel History" of Mithila. This movement, spearheaded by figures like Gajendra Thakur and the *Videha* editorial collective, seeks to dismantle the exclusionary practices of the past, such as the retrospective construction of sub-caste identities like the *Srotriya* which, research suggests, did not exist in its contemporary form in British India before 1800 CE. By writing in the vernacular of Sitamarhi, Mandal asserts a linguistic identity that is both ancient in its association with Sita and modern in its refusal to conform to the Sanskritized standards of the Darbhanga elite.**

**The *Videha* e-journal has provided the technological and critical infrastructure for this assertion. As a multidisciplinary platform, *Videha* facilitates a "Parallel Sahitya Akademi" ecosystem where voices from the "margins"—geographical, linguistic, and social—can find expression. Mandal's work is a cornerstone of this digital renaissance, bridging the gap between traditional print-era pedagogical discipline and the expansive reach of the internet.**

**Table 1: Comparative Evolution of Maithili Literary Frameworks**

| Feature | Traditionalist Framework | Videha/Mandal Parallel Framework |
|---|---|---|
| Linguisti | Standard Maithili | Regional Dialects |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| c Focus | (Darbhanga/Brahminical) | (e.g., Sitamarhi "Pure Maithili") |
| Central Themes | Panji (Genealogy), Classical Poetics, Rituals | Social Realism, Institutional Corruption, Subaltern Resistance |
| Medium | Traditional Print, Academic Journals | Digital E-journals (Videha), Audiobooks, Web Journalism |
| Key Proponents | Ramanath Jha, Traditional Sahitya Akademi | Gajendra Thakur, Acharya Ramanand Mandal, Jan Kavis |
| View of Tradition | Preservative and Obscurantist | Critical Engagement and Reformist |
| Reference Points | | |

**Biographical Profile: The Pedagogical and Scientific Roots of Realism**

**Acharya Ramanand Mandal was born on January 1, 1960, in the village of Pipra Bishanpur, located in the Parihar police station jurisdiction of the Sitamarhi district, Bihar. His family background reflects the agrarian and educational aspirations of the middle-caste communities of Mithila; he is the son of Chandra Devi and the late Rajeshwar Mandal. His marriage to Pramila Devi and his eventual settlement in Muraliyachak, Sitamarhi, provided the stable domestic environment from which he observed the rapid socio-political changes of post-independence Bihar.**

**Mandal’s educational journey is particularly noteworthy for its multidisciplinary nature. He holds an M.Sc. in Chemistry and an M.A. in Hindi. This dual grounding in the hard sciences and the humanities is a**

**defining feature of his literary style. The scientific training manifests in his clinical, almost objective deconstruction of social problems, while his Hindi background allows him to engage with the broader North Indian literary traditions, even as he remains fiercely committed to the Maithili tongue.**

**His professional life as a headmaster and his leadership in the Primary Teachers Association in Dumra provided him with intimate knowledge of the state's micro-level failures. Unlike many writers who observe the rural bureaucracy from the outside, Mandal operated within it for decades. This insider perspective is the bedrock of his realism, allowing him to describe the nuances of administrative bribery, the implementation of educational reforms like the Rajiv Gandhi Panchayati Raj, and the moral erosion of the professional class with authoritative precision.**

**Table 2: Biographical and Educational Matrix**

| Category | Information Detail | Source |
|---|---|---|
| Full Name | Acharya Ramanand Mandal | |
| Date of Birth | January 1, 1960 | |
| Father | Late Rajeshwar Mandal | |
| Mother | Chandra Devi | |
| Wife | Pramila Devi | |
| Academic Degrees | M.Sc. (Chemistry), M.A. (Hindi) | |
| Primary Profession | Retired Headmaster | |
| Social Role | Social Thinker; Association Representative | |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **Geographic Focus** | **Sitamarhi (Muraliyachak)** | |

**It is essential to distinguish the subject of this research—the literary and social thinker Acharya Ramanand Mandal—from other figures with similar names. For instance, snippet identifies a Ramanand Mandal who is a politician from the Suryagarha constituency in Lakhirsarai, associated with the Janata Dal (United). While both figures are active in the public life of Bihar, their spheres of influence and contributions remain distinct; the Acharya is a man of letters and pedagogy, whereas the other is a career politician. Similarly, snippets and mention a Ramanand Mandal born in 1871 who was a Sanskrit scholar; this historical figure serves as a precursor to the modern literary awakening but is not the contemporary writer focused on in *Videha* issue 360.**

**The Linguistic Topology of Sitamarhi: Voice of the Soil**

**The choice of language in Mandal's work is a deliberate act of cultural reclamation. He writes in the specific Maithili dialect spoken in the birthplace of Goddess Sita. In the Maithili literary world, "pure Maithili" is a contested term. For the traditionalists, it often referred to a Sanskritized register. For Mandal, "pure Maithili" refers to the living language of the fields, the local schools, and the village courts of Sitamarhi.**

**This dialectical choice carries significant weight for several reasons:**

1. **Mythological Continuity: By linking his language to the birthplace of Sita, Mandal invokes a sacred geography while simultaneously populating it with modern, secular struggles.**
2. **Subaltern Assertion: The Sitamarhi region has historically been distinct from the Darbhanga power center. Mandal's language asserts the equality of this regional variation within the Maithili corpus.**
3. **Vocabulary of Realism: The local dialect provides a rich vocabulary for agricultural tools, administrative corruption, and social traditions that standard Maithili sometimes lacks or sanitizes.**

**Mandal's strength as a writer is frequently attributed to this vocabulary and his "deep interaction with the good and bad traditions of society". His prose does not shy away from the harsh or the mundane; instead, it uses the local tongue to lend authenticity to the "outspokenness" of his characters.**

**Analytical Deconstruction of the "Five Best Stories"**

**In issue 360 of *Videha*, Acharya Ramanand Mandal identified five short stories as his best works. These stories serve as the primary evidence for his role as a social realist and institutional critic.**

**1. Munhfatpan (The Outspoken)**

**"Munhfatpan" is a profound study of how honesty can become a fatal flaw in a corrupt institutional environment. The story revolves around a strict officer who is characterized by his "munhfatpan"—a lack of filters or a blunt outspokenness. This character trait makes him a polarizing figure; he is admired by the righteous and reviled by those who benefit from the status quo.**

**The narrative details a false case orchestrated by the vigilance department, where witnesses are coerced into signing falsified proceedings. This serves as a searing critique of the state's internal policing mechanisms. The officer is trapped in a decade-long legal battle. While he is eventually exonerated—the "clean chit"—the victory is hollow. The story concludes that "his life is ruined" by the very process of seeking justice. Mandal uses this story to comment not only on law enforcement but on the "lethargic judicial system" that treats procedural victory as a substitute for actual reparations.**

**2. Sharab aa Shabab (The Wine and the Flesh)**

**In this work, Mandal explores the moral decay of the modern professional class. The protagonist is a bank staff member who was once a "good mathematician"—a detail that emphasizes his potential for logic and order. However, the dual temptations of "wine and the flesh" lead to his ethical and social downfall. The story serves as a microscopic look at the psychological fragility of the urbanizing Maithil middle class, suggesting that professional competence is no shield against moral turpitude.**

**3. Mahayajna (The Great Ritual)**

**"Mahayajna" examines the intersection of religion and social stratification. Centered on the Gayatri Mahayajna, the story explores how "caste factors" inevitably permeate even the most sacred rituals. However, unlike the cynical realism of "Munhfatpan," this story offers "rays of hope" found within individuals. It suggests that while the structures of religion are often co-opted by caste dynamics, the human spirit retains a capacity for transcendence and genuine ritual purpose.**

**4. Harbah (The Ploughman)**

**Criticized by Gajendra Thakur as the strongest in the collection, "Harbah" addresses a subject previously ignored in Maithili literature: the system of bonded labor. The story exposes how these oppressive systems are perpetuated under the "name of tradition". The narrative shifts when the younger generation, empowered by education, begins to challenge this systemic exploitation. As a headmaster, Mandal uses this story to emphasize the role of education as an "enabling factor" for social revolution, marking a significant milestone in the Maithili literary engagement with agrarian injustice.**

**5. Jhapan (The Veils)**

**"Jhapan" deals with the domestic and systemic oppression of women. The story covers a range of issues from "unmatched marriages"—a long-standing social ill in Mithila where young women are married to much older men for financial or caste reasons—to the lonely, constrained life of a widow. The "veil" serves as both a literal and metaphorical barrier, hiding the suffering of women from a society that prefers to look away. While critics have noted that this story "needs improvement" in its technical execution, its thematic bravery is consistent with Mandal's role as a social thinker.**

**Table 3: Thematic Synthesis of Principal Short Stories**

| Story Title | Primary Theme | Social/ Institutional Critique | Narrative Resolution |
|---|---|---|---|
| Munhfatpan | Institutional Integrity | Vigilance Dept.; Judicial Lethargy | Exoneration but Personal Ruin |
| Sharab aa Shabab | Moral Turpitude | Professional Middle-Class Decay | Irreversible Moral Downfall |
| Mahayaj | Religious | Persistence of | Existential |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| **na** | **Ritual** | **Caste in Sacred Spaces** | **Hope** |
| **Harbah** | **Bonded Labor** | **Agrarian Slavery; Educational Reform** | **Generational Resistance** |
| **Jhapan** | **Gender Oppression** | **Unmatched Marriages; Widowhood** | **Unresolved Social Constraint** |
| **Reference** | | | |

**Extended Works and the "Mandal" Literary Lineage**

**The literary output of Acharya Ramanand Mandal is not restricted to the five stories reviewed in *Videha* 360. His bibliography includes poetry collections and prose volumes that expand his thematic reach. In 2022, he published *Bhasha Ke Na Bantiyo* (Do Not Divide the Language), a work that likely addresses the linguistic tensions between Maithili and the encroaching influence of Hindi, or perhaps the internal divisions between Maithili dialects. Other notable works include *Shaurya Gaan* (Songs of Valor), *Janak Nandini Janaki*, and the poetry collection *Sanjhiya*.**

**Mandal is part of a significant cluster of writers with the "Mandal" surname who have become central to the *Videha* movement. These writers often share a commitment to social realism and the empowerment of the "Jan" (the people).**

- **Ramdeo Prasad Mandal 'Jharudar': Identified as "Mithila's Bhikhari Thakur," he is celebrated as the first "Jan Kavi" of Maithili and the inventor of the "Jhārū" literary form.**
- **Jagdish Prasad Mandal: A "Farmer-Litterateur" and novelist who focuses on the agrarian experience and critical research.**
- **Rajdeo Mandal: A prolific poet and dramatist whose work "Sharshayya" has been featured alongside Acharya Ramanand Mandal's contributions.**
- **Durganand Mandal: A researcher and writer focused on Maithili theater and literature.**

**The collective presence of these writers suggests a socio-literary phenomenon: the rise of a new intelligentsia in Mithila that is not rooted in the traditional Sanskrit-Pundit tradition but in the rural, agrarian, and pedagogical middle class. Acharya Ramanand Mandal is a bridge within this group, combining the discipline of the headmaster with the sensitivity of the social thinker.**

**Table 4: Key Figures in the Videha Parallel Tradition (Mandal Lineage)**

| Writer | Primary Designation | Key Contribution | Stylistic Framework |
|---|---|---|---|
| Acharya Ramanand Mandal | Retired Headmaster | Realistic Short Stories; Sitamarhi Dialect | Institutional Critique |
| Ramdeo P. Mandal | Mithila's Bhikhari Thakur | First Jan Kavi; Invented "Jhārū" form | Folk-Centric Realism |
| Jagdish Prasad Mandal | Farmer-Litterateur | Agrarian Novels; Critical Analysis | Social-Scientific |
| Rajdeo Mandal | Poet and Screenwriter | Versatility across Poetry/Drama | Experimental Realism |
| Reference | | | |

**Literary Criticism and the Gajendra Thakur Connection**

**Mandal’s relationship with Gajendra Thakur, the editor of *Videha*, is one of mutual intellectual support and critical engagement. Mandal has written an extensive article titled "Literary Figure Gajendra Thakur:**

**Personality and Works," which is included in the audiobook *A Bridge Built for the Sake of Love*. In this article, Mandal analyzes Thakur's multifaceted role as a pioneer of Maithili digital journalism, his contributions to Panji literature, and his development of Maithili-English computer dictionaries.**

**Conversely, Thakur has provided critical reviews of Mandal's work. While praising his vocabulary and deep social interactions, Thakur has been critical of Mandal's tendency to use "abrupt endings" that "do not satisfy the readers fully". Thakur suggests that Mandal should allow his characters more time to evolve so that the "totality" of the social aspect can be described. This critique reveals an important tension in Mandal's work: the conflict between the "social thinker" who wants to deliver a sharp, quick message about an injustice, and the "storyteller" who must adhere to the requirements of narrative craft.**

**Socio-Political Implications: Education and the Future of Mithila**

**A central insight that emerges from Mandal's body of work is the role of education as the primary engine of social change. In "Harbah," it is the "younger generation" with their education that breaks the cycle of bonded labor. In "Munhfatpan," the tragedy is the corruption of the educational administration (the BEO), which should be the very source of enlightenment.**

**Mandal's work suggests that for Mithila to modernize, it must not only preserve its language—as he argues in *Bhasha Ke Na Bantiyo*—but also purify its institutions. His "outspokenness" is a literary strategy to force this purification by exposing the "bad traditions" of society. His residency and work in Sitamarhi place him at the literal and metaphorical center of this struggle, using the "pure Maithili" of the soil to speak truth to the crumbling structures of the state.**

**Conclusion: The Legacy of a Social Thinker**

**Acharya Ramanand Mandal occupies a unique position in the contemporary Maithili landscape. He is not merely a writer of fiction but a documentarian of the rural and institutional reality of North Bihar. His stories serve as a "comment not only regarding the proceedings of the law enforcement agencies but... also a comment on our lethargic judicial system".**

**His contribution to the *Videha* movement is twofold. First, he provides a voice for the Sitamarhi dialect, ensuring that regional variations are**

**celebrated rather than erased by standardization. Second, he brings the perspective of a state-employed educator to literature, detailing the micro-politics of schools and offices with a level of detail that only a decades-long insider could provide.**

**As the Maithili language continues to navigate the challenges of the digital age and the pressures of globalization, the work of Acharya Ramanand Mandal remains a crucial reference point. His insistence on the "pure Maithili" of the birthplace of Sita ensures that the language remains rooted in its geography, while his unflinching realism ensures that it remains relevant to the urgent social questions of the present. While his technical craft may continue to evolve—as suggested by his critics—his moral clarity and his commitment to the "Jan" (the people) of Mithila are already firmly established. In the "Parallel History of Mithila," Mandal stands as a "Ganmanya Kathakar" whose stories penetrate the depths of social disparity and offer, however briefly, "rays of hope" for a more just future.**

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**ADDENDUM 1: The Subaltern Dialectics of Acharya Ramanand Mandal: A Critique within the Videha Parallel History and Navya Nyaya Frameworks**

ADDENDUM 2: **A Critique of Acharya Ramanand Mandal's Literary Corpus**

**ADDENDUM 1**

**The Subaltern Dialectics of Acharya Ramanand Mandal: A Critique within the Videha Parallel History and Navya Nyaya Frameworks**

The literary and philosophical evolution of Mithila has historically been documented through an institutionalized lens that prioritized courtly aesthetics and Brahminical genealogies. However, the intellectual corpus of Acharya Ramanand Mandal (1934–2005) represents a profound epistemological rupture in this tradition. His collective works—spanning poetry in *Bhasha ke na Bantiyo*, investigative essays in *Gagar me Sagar: Nav Vaichariki*, and narrative realism in *Raniyaan Bhikharin*—constitute a systematic attempt to dismantle elite hegemony and linguistic exclusion. By situating Mandal's work within the Videha Parallel History Framework and applying the rigorous logical techniques of Navya Nyaya epistemology, particularly the legacy of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya, one can discern a revolutionary reconstruction of "Maithil"

identity from the perspective of the marginalized "Pachpaniya" society. Mandal’s writing is not merely a creative endeavor; it is a "witness voice" that utilizes logical precision to deconstruct the "sacred" myths that have sustained social stratification in North Bihar for centuries.

**The Videha Parallel History Framework: A Theoretical Paradigm Shift**

The Videha movement, which champions a "Parallel History of Maithili Literature," provides the foundational critical lens for analyzing the works of Acharya Ramanand Mandal. This framework posited that the dominant Maithili literary canon, as institutionalized through the Sahitya Akademi and high-caste print journals, has systematically marginalized writers who work in folk idioms, Dalit traditions, and regional dialects such as Bajjika or Angika. Acharya Ramanand Mandal aligns with this movement by explicitly rejecting the "standardization" (Manak) of Maithili, which he identifies as a tool of linguistic and social oppression.

The Videha manifesto describes itself as an "alternative archive" created to challenge an "onslaught on dignity" perpetrated by elite-led government academies. It argues that mainstream Maithili history is a "Brahmin-centered court culture" that has suppressed the democratic-spiritual corpus of the masses. Mandal’s poetry collection, *Bhasha ke na Bantiyo* (Do Not Divide the Language), serves as a poetic manifestation of this manifesto, pleading for a linguistic unity that encompasses all regional variations—Pachhimi (Western/Bajjika), Dachhini (Southern/Angika), and Thethi.

**Deconstructing the "Official" Tradition**

The "Official Tradition" of Maithili history, exemplified by historians like Mm. Parmeshwar Jha, emphasizes the *Panji Prabandh*—the genealogical records of Maithil Brahmins and Kayasthas—as a monumental social achievement. In contrast, the Parallel History movement, and Mandal in his essays, denounce the Panji system as a tool of "Brahminical patriarchy" and social exclusion. Mandal’s research in *Gagar me Sagar* challenges the very roots of this identity, suggesting that the "Succha Maithil" (True Maithil) definition used by the elite is an artificial construct meant to preserve institutional power.

| Historical Paradigm | Focus of Documentation | Social Underpinning | Linguistic Standard |
|---|---|---|---|

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Official Tradition** | Courtly poetry, Panji records, Sanskritized prose | Brahmin-Kayastha (Succha Maithil) hegemony | *Sotipura* / Standard (Manak) Maithili |
| **Parallel Tradition** | Folk idioms, Dalit icons, Bajjika/Angika literature | Pachpaniya (Marginalized OBCs, Dalits, Muslims) | *Desil Bayna* / Regional varieties/ Dialectical spectrum |

Mandal's position is that of a "sachetaka" (alerter) who exposes how this official tradition has erased figures like the subaltern singer Mangan Khabas or the revolutionary martyr Ramphal Mandal from the Maithil consciousness. His work insists that the vitality of the language resides not in its "purity" but in its ability to represent the "missing portions" of society—the non-represented aspects of caste, gender, and socio-economic struggle.

**Navya Nyaya Epistemology: The Logic of Subaltern Reclamation**

A defining feature of the critique of Acharya Ramanand Mandal is the application of Navya Nyaya techniques to his truth-claims. Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya, the 14th-century Mithila philosopher and author of the *Tattvacintāmaṇi*, founded the Navya Nyaya ("New Logic") school to provide a rigorous, ontologically committed analysis of how the world as cognized corresponds to reality. Mandal, though writing in a modern subaltern context, utilizes a form of "New Logic" to interrogate the social and linguistic structures of Mithila.

**The Application of Avacchedaka (Delimiter) to Maithil Identity**

In Navya Nyaya, an *avacchedaka* is a determining property that delimits the scope of a subject to ensure a definition is neither too broad nor too narrow. Acharya Ramanand Mandal performs a radical logical operation on the term "Maithil" by redefining its *avacchedaka*. In elite discourse, the property of being a "Maithil" is delimited by Brahminical lineage and registration in the *Panji* records. Mandal, however, argues that "Maithil-ness" must be delimited by the use of the mother tongue and residence within the geographical boundaries of Mithila, regardless of *varna*.

He critiques the "Succha Maithil" definition as a violation of the logical principle of *vyapti* (invariable concomitance/pervasion). If the category "Maithil" (the *paksha*) is supposed to encompass the people of the land, then a definition that excludes the "Pachpaniya" and other laborers suffers from the fallacy of *avyapti* (narrow application). Mandal's logic suggests that if the soil (the land) is not "untouchable," then the words spoken by those who work the soil cannot be excluded from the definition of the language.

**Anvaya-Vyatireka and the Logic of Linguistic Alienation**

Mandal employs the method of *anvaya-vyatireka* (agreement and difference) to analyze the causal relationship between linguistic standardization and social alienation.

1. **Anvaya (Agreement):** Wherever there is an institutional insistence on *Manak* (Standard) Maithili as the only valid form of expression, there is a corresponding exclusion and silence of the subaltern classes.
2. **Vyatireka (Difference):** Where such an insistence is absent—as in the "Parallel" stream or folk traditions—the subaltern voice (e.g., in Bajjika or Angika) is present, vibrant, and expressive.

Through this deduction, Mandal concludes in *Bhasha ke na Bantiyo* that the fragmentation of Maithili into "dialects" like Bajjika and Angika is a "political arrow" (rajnaitik teer) intended to weaken the collective strength of the language's speakers. His plea to "not divide the language" is an attempt to restore the *vyapti* (universal connection) of the Maithili-speaking world against the "discriminatory logic" of the elite.

| **Logical Term (Nyaya)** | **Traditional Definition** | **Mandal's Application** |
|---|---|---|
| **Paksha (Subject)** | The hill (inferring fire) | The Maithil Identity/Society |
| **Hetu (Reason)** | Smoke (sign of fire) | Language use and shared suffering |
| **Sadhya (Probandum** | Fire (what is proved) | Democratic equality and representation |

| ) | | |
|---|---|---|
| **Vyapti (Pervasion)** | Connection between smoke and fire | Connection between shared language and common identity |

**Linguistic Resistance: Bajjika and the Politics of Speech**

The decision of Acharya Ramanand Mandal to write in "Western Maithili" (Bajjika) is a deliberate act of linguistic defiance. The institutionalized literary establishment often dismisses Bajjika as "broken Hindi" or a mere "raag" (dialect) inferior to the Sanskritized standard of Darbhanga and Madhubani. Mandal's own realization—that his native speech was not "broken Hindi" but an integral part of the Maithili spectrum—highlights the success of elite efforts to create a "broken society" where different regions remain unknown to one another.

In *Bhasha ke na Bantiyo*, Mandal describes language as a "flow" (pravah) that emerges naturally from the environment. He views the "ghost of standardization" as a restrictive cage that prevents the "soil's language" from flourishing. By writing his poetry and stories in the Bajjika idiom, Mandal provides a "pratyaksha" (direct perception) of the lived reality of the common man, bypassing the "inferential fallacies" of institutional grammar.

**The Standardisation Myth as Cultural Enclosure**

Mandal argues that while standardisation might serve a purpose in education, in the realm of literature, it functions as a "laughable context" that limits creativity. He references George Grierson's linguistic surveys to prove that Maithili has always been a diverse spectrum of styles—including Pachhimi (Western) and Dachhini (Southern)—and that prioritizing one "standard" is an artificial imposition designed to maintain the hegemony of the "Sotipura" Brahmin class.

| Linguistic Category | Official Status | Mandal's Re-evaluation |
|---|---|---|
| **Manak (Standard)** | The "Pure" and "Correct" Maithili | A tool of exclusion and "toxic" elitism |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **Bajjika (Western)** | Dialect / Broken Hindi | The "Mother Language" of the Western region |
| **Angika (Southern)** | Dialect / "Chhika-Chhiki" | An integral "limb" of the Maithili body |
| **Thethi/Raar** | Sub-standard / "Vulgar" | The authentic "Desil Bayna" of the workers |

Mandal's poem "Angika Bajjika" asserts that these labels are "disappearing" the মিঠগর (sweet) speech of the people. His logic mirrors the Navya Nyaya concept of *abhava* (non-existence)—specifically, he argues that the "absence" of these dialects in official literature is not a natural lack but a "constructed non-existence" enforced by political power.

**The Two Vidyapatis: Reclaiming the Subaltern Icon**

One of the most provocative intellectual interventions in Mandal's *Gagar me Sagar* is the theory of "The Two Vidyapatis." Following the research promoted by the Videha framework, Mandal argues that there is a fundamental distinction between the famous *Padavali* poet (the *Aadi-Kavi*) and the courtly Sanskrit writer Vidyapati Thakkurah (1350–1435).

Mandal suggests that the *Padavali* poet was likely a subaltern figure, possibly from the "Nai" (barber) or "Charmakar" (cobbler) community, whose "Desil Bayna" (native speech) resonated with the common people. He notes that even today, mahouts, cowherds, and cart-drovers in Purnia and Saharsa perform the "Vidyapati dance-drama" with deep emotional connection, while the "respectable society" often considers it beneath their dignity.

**The Scholarly "Glitch" in Hagiography**

Mandal critiques the institutionalized process of "Brahminization" that conflated these two figures to claim the folk poet's popularity for the courtly elite. He uses logical *pariksha* (examination) to highlight discrepancies in the "Official" biography:

- **Birthplace:** The official birthplace of the courtly Vidyapati (Bisfi) has no Brahmin population within five kilometers, but it is densely populated by the "Nai" community.

- **Language:** The courtly writer wrote in Sanskrit and Avahatta, while the *Padavali* is written in the "Desil Bayna" that elite scholars later "edited" to fit Sanskritized standards.

By reclaiming Vidyapati as the "Poet of Plowmen and Sowers," Mandal performs a Navya Nyaya *nirnaya* (ascertainment of truth), stripping away the "superimposed" identities created by elite historians. This reclamation is vital to the Parallel History tradition because it restores the "agency" of the subaltern in the creation of Maithil culture.

**Theology of the Oppressed: Veer Sita and the Dalit Devotional**

Acharya Ramanand Mandal's theological critiques represent a radical departure from traditional Maithil piety, which often portrays divinity as the preserve of high-caste ritual. In *Gagar me Sagar* and *Bhasha ke na Bantiyo*, he reinterprets the central figures of Mithila—Rama and Sita—through a lens of social empowerment and justice.

**Veer Sita: The Bhumija Warrior**

In the institutionalized narrative, Sita is often relegated to the role of the passive, suffering daughter-in-law. Mandal, drawing on the *Mithila Ramayana* of Sant Lal Das, reconstructs her as a "Veer Nari" (Warrior Woman) and a manifestation of "Parashakti" (Supreme Power). He highlights the "Bhumija" (daughter of the soil) aspect of her birth, linking her directly to the land and the laborers who till it.

Mandal points to the specific mythological moment in the *Pushkar Kand* of Lal Das's Ramayana where Sita assumes the form of Kali to slay the "Sahasanan Ravana" (a demon more powerful than the ten-headed Ravana) after Rama is rendered unconscious in battle. This "Veer Sita" identity serves as a postcolonial and feminist critique, challenging the patriarchy that has "exiled" the strong, independent woman from the Maithil canon.

**Reimagining "Barham Baba": From Brahmin to Buddha**

Mandal's interrogation of "Barham Baba"—the ubiquitous folk deity of Mithila villages—is a masterpiece of social deconstruction. Institutional narratives often conflate "Barham Baba" (the village spirit) with "Brahmin" (the caste), portraying the deity as a jeneu-wearing priest. Mandal, citing historians like Pro. Mayanand Mishra, argues that these deities were originally "Buddhas in meditation" under Peepal trees, later "Brahminized" to integrate the masses into the varna hierarchy.

He critiques the singing of "Brahmin Babu" songs at Maithil cultural events as a "shameful act" (sharmnak kritya) of cultural hegemony. In his logic, the divine "Brahma" is universal—"Aham Brahmasmi"—and to limit it to a single caste is a logical fallacy that denies the divinity of the marginalized. This theological shift is intended to liberate the "mental slaves" of the Brahminical order and restore a sense of universal dignity.

| Icon | Institutional Representation | Mandal's Parallel Interpretation |
|---|---|---|
| **Sita** | Passive, ideal wife; victim of Ravana | "Veer Sita"; Parashakti; the warrior who slays Sahasanan Ravana |
| **Rama** | The supreme Lord/Avatara | A partner in a human drama; sometimes a "silent witness" to injustice |
| **Barham Baba** | A deified Brahmin priest | A "Brahma" or "Buddha"; a universal spirit of wisdom |
| **Vidyapati** | The courtly scholar of Bisfi | The folk poet of the masses (possibly subaltern) |

**Narrative Realism in Raniyaan Bhikharin: Mirroring the Margin**

The short story collection *Raniyaan Bhikharin* (Raniyaan the Beggar) brings Mandal's theoretical critiques into the realm of human experience. These stories are "witness accounts" of village life, focusing on the "invisible portions" of society—the laborers, exploited women, and victims of the "standard" social order.

**Exploitation and Maternal Agency**

The title story, "Raniyaan Bhikharin," portrays a 25-year-old woman suffering from polio who begs at a bus stand and is subsequently exploited by a bus conductor. Mandal's narrative does not merely seek pity; it critiques the structural failures of the "Official" Mithila that leaves such women vulnerable. Raniyan's eventual assertion of agency—moving away to protect her child—is

a subtle rejection of the society that labels her an "untouchable" beggar while simultaneously preying on her body.

**The Secret Genealogies of Caste**

In stories like "Jaivik Pita" (Biological Father) and "Warish" (The Heir), Mandal explores the "hypocrisy" of the caste system. In "Jaivik Pita," a young landlord ("Chhotka Malik") discovers that his biological father is actually a "Khabas" (servant), a secret his mother kept to preserve the elite lineage's "honor".

This story functions as a Navya Nyaya critique of *varna*: if caste is determined by "birth" (*jati*), but the biological truth of that birth is a secret of the servant class, then the entire edifice of caste superiority is logically bankrupt. Mandal uses this narrative "glitch" to show that social status is a "construction of elite discourse" rather than an inherent truth.

**The Transnational Alienation of Mithila**

Mandal also addresses the impact of global capitalism on the Maithil family. In "Adarsh Putra" (The Ideal Son), he contrasts a village school teacher who serves his aging parents with an engineer in America who cannot return for his father’s funeral. This story highlights the "transnational alienation" of the Maithil diaspora and critiques a system where "success" is defined by fleeing the land. It aligns with his essay "Mithila se Palayan" (Migration from Mithila), where he argues that migration is both a tragedy and a necessary tool for the economic advancement of the marginalized.

**Political Vision: Mithila Rajya and the "North Bihar" Reality**

Acharya Ramanand Mandal’s advocacy for a "Mithila Rajya" (Mithila State) is grounded in social justice rather than ethnic chauvinism. He warns that a state created out of "ghrina" (hatred) for other regions (like Magadh) will only lead to the kind of instability seen in the "Madhesh" region of Nepal.

**Sitamadhi: The Democratic Capital**

Mandal proposes **Sitamadhi** as the ideal capital for a new Mithila state, rejecting the traditionally favored Darbhanga. His logic is symbolic: Darbhanga represents the era of "Raj" (landlordism), while Sitamadhi represents the "Janmabhoomi" of Sita and the democratic roots of the ancient "Videha" republic.

He points to the current administrative reality of "North Bihar" as a functional Mithila. The existence of separate "North Bihar Power Distribution" and "North Bihar Gramin Bank" entities serves as *pramana* (proof) that the region

is already distinct from the south. His demand for a state is not for the benefit of the "Bhurabaal" (elite castes) but to ensure a "samadhan" (solution) for the "Pachpaniya" society that has been neglected by the centralized administration in Patna.

| Entity | Symbolic Meaning in Mandal’s Framework |
|---|---|
| **Darbhanga** | Hegemony, Landlordism, "Standard" Maithili |
| **Sitamadhi** | Democracy, Subalternity, the "Soil's Language" |
| **North Bihar** | The empirical, logical reality of Mithila |
| **Magadh/ Patna** | The "Central Metropolis" that requires a regional "Partner" |

**Intersections with Western Critical Theory**

Mandal’s work invites a multi-layered analysis that bridges traditional Indian thought with Western critical frameworks.

**Subaltern Studies and "History from Below"**

Mandal’s focus on the "mute society" aligns perfectly with the methodology of Antonio Gramsci and Ranajit Guha. He attempts to "rectify the elitist bias" in Maithili history by recovering the contributions of non-elites as the primary "agents of social change". His writing functions as the "voice of the underclass" within the networks of capitalism and internal colonialism.

**Postcolonialism and the "Third Space"**

By blending the high logic of Navya Nyaya with the "vulgar" folk speech of Bajjika, Mandal creates what Homi Bhabha calls a "third space" of hybridity. This space challenges both the colonial legacy of the British (who categorized the languages) and the "internal colonialism" of the Maithil elite (who enforced the standards). His critique of "Manak" Maithili as an "onslaught on dignity" reflects the postcolonial struggle against the "metropolis" of high-caste culture.

**Marxist Critique of Caste and Class**

Mandal's identification of the "Brahmin-Kayastha alliance" as a ruling class that governed Mithila for 808 years is a form of Marxist class analysis applied to the Indian caste context. He views "Manak" Maithili as a "language of the oppressor," proving that linguistic standards are often part of the "ideological superstructure" used to maintain the "economic base" of landholding elites.

**Navya Nyaya as a Tool of Social Audit**

Mandal's intellectual project is, in many ways, an "epistemological audit" of Maithili institutions. He uses the precision of the *Tattvacintāmaṇi* to expose the "fallacies" in the official record.

**The RTI Exposé and Institutional "Abhava"**

The Parallel History movement, which Mandal supports, used Right to Information (RTI) data (2011–14) to show that over 90% of Sahitya Akademi assignments went to relatives or friends of the advisory board, with "zero" assignments given to authors of the parallel tradition. This is a modern application of the Nyaya concept of *anupalabdhi* (non-perception)—the absence of subaltern writers in official institutions is not a matter of a lack of talent, but a "verifiable non-existence" enforced by systemic bias.

**The "Dooshan Panji" (Blackbook of Faults)**

Videha's use of digitized genealogical records to create a "Dooshan Panji" (Blackbook) is a form of logical *pariksha*. By exposing "secrets" suppressed by elite historians—such as the claim that the philosopher Gaṅgeśa himself may have been born of an inter-caste union—Mandal and the Videha movement seek to achieve *Nirnaya* (ascertainment of truth) that levels the playing field for all Maithils.

**Synthesis of Indian Poetics: Rasa and Dhvani**

Despite his rigorous logic, Mandal's work remains deeply poetic, rooted in the traditional Indian concepts of *Rasa* (aesthetic flavor) and *Dhvani* (suggestion).

- **Karuna Rasa (Sentiment of Pathos):** This is the dominant flavor in *Bhasha ke na Bantiyo*, as he mourns the "injured" state of the Maithili language and the suffering of the laborers.
- **Vira Rasa (Heroic Sentiment):** This sentiment emerges in his call for the marginalized to wake up—"Sutal Maithil के, जगावे वाला हम" (I am the one who wakes the sleeping Maithil).
- **Dhvani (Suggestion):** The suggested meaning in his narratives is always the "absence" of justice. In *Raniyaan Bhikharin*, the "suggestion" is that the true

"beggar" is the society that lacks the moral courage to recognize its own children.

**Future Outlook: Toward a Synthetic Historiography**

The legacy of Acharya Ramanand Mandal is a call for a "Synthetic Historiography" that refuses to see Maithili as the exclusive preserve of an elite. His work proves that the "Parallel History of Maithili Literature" is not just a list of alternative texts, but a fundamental "shift in perspective" that reintegrates Dalit folk heroes, regional dialects, and modern dissenters into a unified account of the Maithili-speaking world.

Mandal's "Nav Vaichariki" provides the "clean slate" for a representational future. By utilizing the logical rigors of his ancestors—the logic of Gaṅgeśa and the spirit of Janaka—he successfully condensed a "Sea into a Jar" (*Gagar me Sagar*), offering a potent ideology that transforms the "missing portions" of society into the "nayakas" (heroes) of their own history.

**The Future of "Mithila-ness"**

As Maithili writers navigate the complexities of the 21st century, Mandal's vision offers a path forward:

- **Inclusivity:** A language that embraces Bajjika and Angika as its own "limbs".
- **Secularism:** A culture that recognizes its pluralistic roots in Hinduism, Buddhism, and Islam.
- **Justice:** A political state that prioritizes the "Pachpaniya" and the "soil's laborers" over the ghosts of landlordism.

Acharya Ramanand Mandal remains a "sachetaka" for the ages, a scientist of chemistry who understood the "chemical reactions" of social justice, and a poet who proved that the "mother language" belongs to all who are born of the Mithila soil. His work is the "touchstone of intelligence" for a new generation, a "whetstone for gold" that continues to sharpen the dialectical edge of Maithili literature.

In the final analysis, Mandal's corpus is an "internally coherent system" that mirrors the complexity and range of the *Tattvacintāmaṇi*. He demonstrated that through logical precision and narrative empathy, the "throbbing human heart" of the margins can finally achieve its rightful place in the canon of Mithila. His legacy is the "representational future" of Maithili—one that is "naturally inclusive and strong," where the "Bhumija" daughter and the "Pachpaniya" laborer finally find their voice.

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**ADDENDUM 2**

**A Critique of Acharya Ramanand Mandal's Literary Corpus**

**1. The Videha Parallel History Framework: A Subaltern Chronotope**

The "Videha Parallel History" framework, pioneered by Gajendra Thakur, posits that the history of Mithila must be read through a parallel lens—one that bypasses the elite, Sanskrit-centric narratives to focus on the linguistic and cultural continuity of the masses.

- **Critique:** Ramanand Mandal's works (such as those featured in *Videha-360*) act as primary "parallel" texts. Unlike the classical *Kavya* tradition that romanticizes Mithila's past, Mandal's prose—often described as "pure Maithili spoken in the birthplace of Sita"—functions as a **counter-archive**.
- **Parallelism:** By documenting the "unspoken" (the struggles of the retired headmaster, the corruption in the vigilance department, and the life of the common laborer), his literature fulfills the Videha mandate of creating a history that runs alongside, yet distinct from, official state or elite histories.

**2. Navya-Nyaya Epistemology: The Technique of *Avacchedakatā***

The Navya-Nyaya school, founded by **Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya** in Mithila, uses a precise technical language to define the "limiting properties" (*avacchedakatā*) of knowledge.

- **Application to Mandal's Works:** If we apply the Navya-Nyaya technique of *Anvikshiki* (critical inquiry) to Mandal's short stories, we find a meticulous "mapping" of social cognition.
- **The Logic of Perception (*Pratyaksha*):** In his story about a "strict officer wrongly trapped," Mandal employs a narrative technique akin to *Savyabhicara* (the fallacy of irregular middle). The "public perception" of the officer's outspokenness is the *hetu* (reason) for his downfall.
- **Structural Precision:** His prose lacks the "ornamental fog" of traditional literature; it possesses the *Laghava* (parsimony/brevity) valued by Gaṅgeśa. Each character is defined by their *Dharma* (essential attribute) relative to their social station, creating a logical "grid" of Maithili society.

**3. Western Criticism: Realism, Naturalism, and the "Small Man"**

From a Western perspective, Mandal's work can be analyzed through the lens of **Social Realism** and **New Historicism**.

- **The "Small Man" Motif:** Reminiscent of Chekhov or Gogol, Mandal's protagonists are often "minor" figures—retired teachers or middle-class employees—caught in the bureaucratic machinery.
- **Narrative Theory:** His works utilize a **Homodiegetic** perspective, where the narrator's voice is deeply embedded in the local linguistic milieu. This creates a "thick description" (Clifford Geertz) of Sitamarhi's socio-political landscape.
- **Dialectic of Power:** Following Foucault, Mandal's depiction of the "vigilance department" and "false cases" illustrates the *micro-physics of power.* He shows how language (the "outspokenness" of the hero) becomes a site of punishment.

**4. Indian Literary Theory: *Rasa* and *Dhvani* in the Mundane**

While classical theory focuses on *Sringara* (Erotic) or *Veera* (Heroic) Rasas, Mandal's work gravitates towards **Karuna** (Pathos) and **Bibhatsa** (Disgust at corruption).

- **Laukika vs. Alaukika:** Mandal brings the *Rasa* experience down from the *Alaukika* (transcendental) plane to the *Laukika* (mundane). The "aesthetic relish" in his stories comes from the recognition of truth (*Satya*), aligning with the Gandhian aesthetics of simplicity.
- **Dhvani (Suggestion):** The "Pure Maithili" he uses carries a *Dhvani* that signifies more than the literal meaning; it signifies a resistance to the "Hindi-ization" of the Maithili heartland.

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**Summary Table: Critical Perspectives**

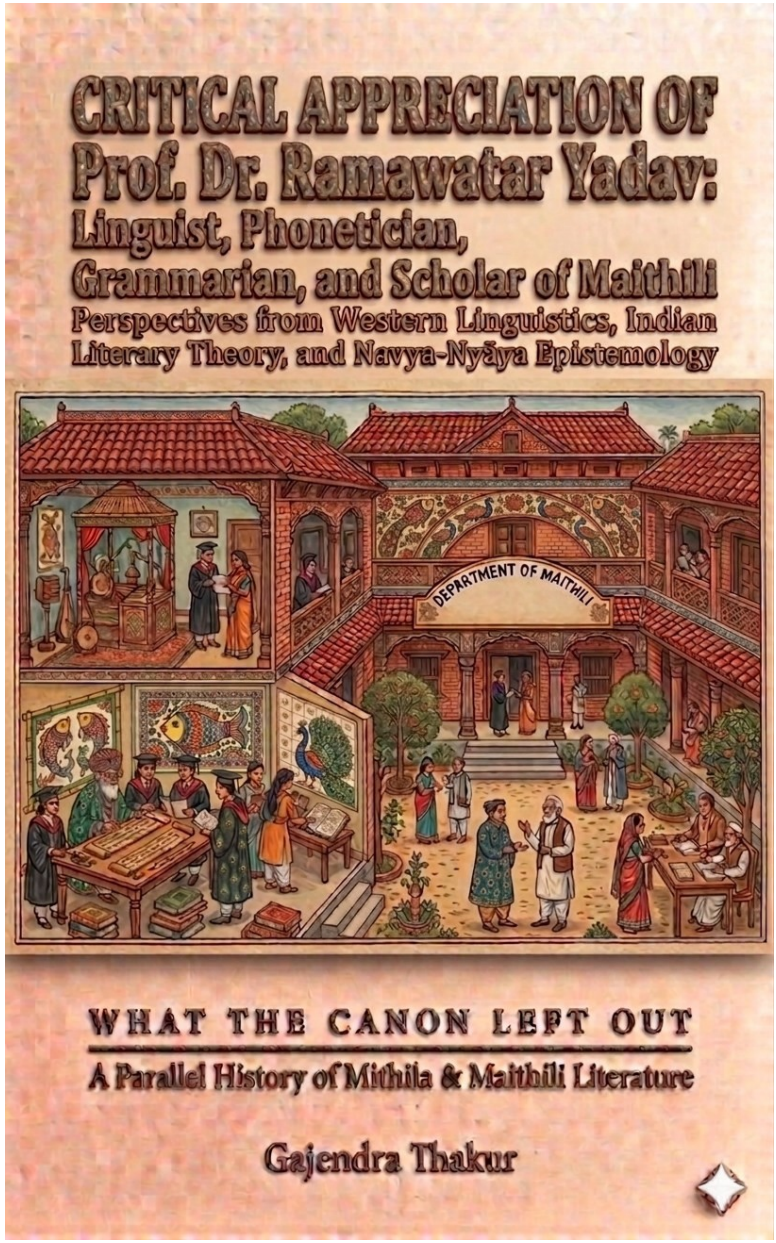
| Framework | Key Concept | Observation on Ramanand Mandal |
|---|---|---|
| **Videha Parallel History** | Subaltern Archive | His works document the lived reality of the non-elite Maithil. |
| **Navya-Nyaya (Gaṅgeśa)** | *Avacchedaka tā* | Narrative precision; limiting the scope of truth to verifiable social facts. |

| Framework | Key Concept | Observation on Ramanand Mandal |
|---|---|---|
| **Western Realism** | Social Critique | Portrayal of individuals crushed by institutional corruption. |
| **Indian Poetics** | *Laukika Rasa* | Aestheticizing the struggles of the "retired" and "ordinary" man. |

**References & Resources**

- **Primary Texts:** Videha e-Journal Archive (Specifically *Videha-360* and *Sadeh* series).
- **Methodological Framework:** *A Survey of Maithili Literature* by Radhakrishna Chaudhary; *Tattvacintāmaṇi* of Gaṅgeśa (for logic).
- **Critical Essays:** "Literary Figure Gajendra Thakur: Personality and Works" by Acharya Ramanand Mandal (found in *A Bridge Built for the Sake of Love* by Ashish Anchinhar).

**LESSON 064 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**



# CRITICAL APPRECIATION OF

**Prof. Dr. Ramawatar Yadav**

(1942–)

*Linguist, Phonetician, Grammarian, and Scholar of Maithili*

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*Perspectives from Western Linguistics, Indian Literary Theory, and Navya-Nyāya Epistemology*

## Preface

The present volume constitutes a comprehensive critical appreciation of the life, scholarship, and intellectual legacy of Professor Dr. Ramawatar Yadav — one of the most distinguished linguists to emerge from the Mithila region and the foremost descriptive grammarian of the Maithili language in the modern era. Born in 1942, Yadav's scholarly journey took him from the Terai of Nepal to the universities of Kansas, Mainz, Kiel, and Kentucky, before culminating in a long and productive career at Tribhuvan University, Kathmandu.

This critical appreciation draws upon the four source documents provided by the *Videha* archive — namely, *A Reference Grammar of Maithili* (Mouton de Gruyter, 1996), *Videha* Issue 396 (the special Ramawatar Yadav issue, 2024), *RamawatarYadav_AalekhSanchayan* (a collection of his scholarly articles), as well as a wide range of secondary materials gathered from international linguistic publications. The analysis proceeds through multiple theoretical lenses: Western structural and generative linguistics (Saussure, Chomsky, Halliday, Fries), Indian grammatical theory (Pāṇini, Bhartṛhari, Mīmāṃsā), and the Navya-Nyāya epistemological tradition of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya, which constitutes a distinctive and underrecognized conceptual ground for evaluating Yadav's treatment of honorificity, śabda (verbal testimony), and meaning-making in Maithili.

## Part I: Biographical and Intellectual Profile

### 1.1 Life and Institutional Trajectory

Ramawatar Yadav was born in 1942 in the Mithila region. His early academic formation was within the teaching of English language and literature, which he practiced at the College of Education and Patan College from 1965 to 1973.

This pedagogical grounding in English gave him a dual vantage point — that of a native speaker of an endangered yet classical Eastern Indo-Aryan language, and that of a trained practitioner of English linguistics, including phonetics and phonology. From 1973 to 1990, he taught English phonetics, phonology, and theoretical and applied linguistics to MA students at Tribhuvan University.

Yadav received his MPhil (1977) and PhD (1979) in linguistics from the **University of Kansas**, Lawrence, USA, where his doctoral dissertation, *Maithili Phonetics and Phonology*, established him as a leading voice in experimental phonology and the acoustic analysis of South Asian languages. He subsequently held a prestigious **Alexander von Humboldt Postdoctoral Research Fellowship** at the Department of Indology, University of Mainz, Germany (1983–84), and a **Senior Fulbright Visiting Scholarship** at the Linguistics Program, University of Kentucky, Lexington, USA (1989). A second Alexander von Humboldt fellowship followed at the Department of General and Indogermanic Linguistics, University of Kiel, Germany (1989). These fellowships provided the institutional conditions for completing the definitive reference grammar.

He held multiple educational administrative positions at Tribhuvan University, eventually becoming one of its most senior linguists. Throughout his career, he maintained close scholarly ties with Werner Winter (Kiel), Gregory T. Stump (Kentucky), and Georg Buddruss (Mainz). Stump's engagement with the manuscript of *A Reference Grammar of Maithili* and his incisive editorial contributions are acknowledged in the grammar's preface as indispensable.

## 1.2 The Scholarly Vocation: Language Advocacy and Scientific Rigour

Yadav's intellectual project was simultaneously a scientific and political one. From the outset, a dual commitment shapes his entire corpus: the application of rigorous modern linguistic methodology to a language that had historically been misclassified, and the restoration of Maithili's standing as an autonomous, complex, and fully grammaticalized natural language.

As he documented in the opening chapter of the reference grammar, Maithili had been variously treated — by John Beames (1872–79), by Hoernle (1880), and by Grierson (1883–87) — as a dialect of Bengali, Eastern Hindi, or the spurious grouping called 'Bihari.' Yadav systematically dismantled this misclassification, demonstrating through synchronic morphology, syntax, phonology, and semantics that Maithili possesses independent systemic features — notably the near-total loss of the Old Indo-Aryan gender system, the

absence of grammatical number in modern Maithili, and above all, the extraordinary complexity of its honorificity distinctions and verbal agreement morphology — that set it apart decisively from all neighbouring languages.

The Videha Issue 396 (2024), a special issue dedicated to Yadav as *bhāṣāvid* (language scientist), also highlights his role in drawing attention to the sociolinguistic dimension of caste in Maithili grammar: he was, in the words of Subhash Chandra Yadav, 'the only linguist who gave even a little thought' to the Dalit Maithili, to the *pacpanniyā Maithili* — the Maithili of the lower castes, distinct in its vocabulary and morphology from the Brahmanical standard tacitly assumed by all previous grammarians.

# Part II: Major Works and Their Critical Assessment

## 2.1 Maithili Phonetics and Phonology (PhD Dissertation, University of Kansas, 1979; published 1984)

This doctoral dissertation constitutes the first book-length study of the phonetics and phonology of Maithili and was published in 1984 (Seldan and Tamm). Its five chapters trace a path from theoretical introduction, through segmental phonology, to instrumental phonetics: a fiberoptic study of voicing and aspiration, and acoustic analyses of both oral and nasalized vowels, followed by a study of word stress.

The theoretical framework is **generative phonology** as developed in the tradition of Chomsky and Halle's *The Sound Pattern of English* (1968). As early as 1976, Yadav had applied this framework to the question of aspirated consonants in colloquial Maithili, arguing against the 'unit' interpretation in favour of a cluster interpretation, a position elaborated in a series of papers (1976, 1979, 1980, 1982, 1984). His 1979 paper on the influence of aspiration on vowel duration in Maithili (*South Asian Languages Analysis*) and his 1982 study of the acoustic characteristics of vowel nasalization in Maithili (*Indian Linguistics*) drew on experimental phonetics to illuminate structures inadequately captured by purely distributional analysis.

The fiberoptic study of voicing and aspiration is particularly significant: at the time of writing, instrumental phonetic research on South Asian languages was rare, and Yadav's use of fiberoptics to study the laryngeal phonetics of Maithili consonants placed this work in dialogue with the finest experimental tradition in phonetics, represented by scholars like Peter Ladefoged. The methodology

anticipates what would later become standard in the field of laboratory phonology.

The theoretical implications of this work intersect with a fundamental question raised within Indian grammatical thought by the Mīmāṃsakas and Vaiyākaraṇas: what is the minimal phonological unit of language? The Mīmāṃsakas held the *varṇa* (phoneme) as primary; the Vaiyākaraṇas held the sentence (*vākya*); the Naiyāyikas held the *pada* (word). Yadav's experimental approach essentially locates this question in acoustic-phonetic measurement, grounding the abstract in the articulatory and auditory evidence. This is, in methodological spirit, deeply compatible with Gaṅgeśa's insistence on *pramāṇa* — valid epistemic evidence — over received classification.

## 2.2 A Reference Grammar of Maithili (Mouton de Gruyter, Berlin/New York, 1996)

This is Yadav's magnum opus. Published in the prestigious *Trends in Linguistics: Documentation* series (Vol. 11) of Walter de Gruyter, it constitutes the definitive synchronic description of the Maithili language. At 414 pages, it covers: (1) a century of Maithili grammatical tradition; (2) the sound system and script; (3) the noun and noun phrase; (4) pronouns; (5) adjectives, modifiers, determiners, and numerals; (6) the verb and verb phrase; (7) adverbs, postpositions, clitics, interjections, and particles; (8) sentence types; and (9) the syntax and semantics of simple and complex sentences.

### *2.2.1 The Grammatical Tradition Survey*

The opening chapter is itself a contribution to the historiography of Maithili linguistics. Yadav surveys, with discriminating judgment, the traditional grammarians (Dinabandhu Jha's *Mithilā-Bhāṣā-Vidyotana*, 1946, written in the Pāṇinian sūtra tradition; Govind Jha's *Laghu Vidyotana*, 1963), the historical grammarians (Grierson, Hoernle, Chatterji, Jeffers, Thiel-Horstmann), the pedagogical grammarians, and the structural-descriptive scholars. His critique of the traditional grammars is sharp but fair: the Sanskritic superimposition, he argues, 'tends to distort the facts of Maithili, and even skews the conclusions drawn about it' — a point of critical importance for all subsequent work.

This critique resonates with the broader tradition of **postcolonial linguistics** as theorized by scholars like Braj Kachru and Robert Phillipson: when a language is described through the grammatical categories of a prestigious neighbour (Sanskrit, Hindi, or English), the distinctive structures of the target language are rendered invisible. Yadav's decision to use modern structural and generative

categories rather than Pāṇinian ones is itself an act of methodological decolonization — though one that simultaneously draws on the sophistication of the Western comparative and typological tradition.

### *2.2.2 The Phonology Chapters*

Chapter 2 provides a comprehensive inventory of Maithili phonemes, covering vowels (including a detailed treatment of vowel nasalization and length), consonants (with the critical treatment of aspirated consonants), consonant clusters, vowel clusters, stress and intonation, morphophonemics, and script. The phonemic inventory distinguishes Maithili clearly from Hindi, Bengali, and Nepali, and the morphophonemic rules — particularly the schwa deletion rule and the stem-internal alternation between *a* and *ā* — are described with exemplary precision and illustrated with hundreds of glossed examples.

The treatment of **nasalization** is especially notable. Nasalization in Maithili operates at the phonemic level — a distinction between oral and nasal vowels is grammatically significant — and Yadav's acoustic evidence (1982) demonstrated that nasal coarticulation patterns in Maithili differ measurably from neighbouring languages. This is relevant to the classical debate in Indian phonology between the *anunāsika* (nasal resonance) theorists and the strict segmentalists: Maithili provides empirical data that bridges the phonemic and phonetic levels in ways that illuminate this theoretical controversy.

### *2.2.3 The Noun, Case, and Honorificity System*

Chapter 3 on the noun and noun phrase identifies one of Maithili's most typologically unusual features: the near-total loss of grammatical gender. While Sanskrit has three genders (masculine, feminine, neuter) and Hindi retains two (masculine, feminine), modern Maithili's gender system is, as Yadav documents, 'governed mainly by the sex of the animate object; it is not grammatical as in Sanskrit and Hindi.' This is a major structural innovation in the history of Indo-Aryan morphology.

The case system of Maithili, detailed in section 3.3, presents a rich postpositional morphology. Yadav identifies and analyses the nominative, accusative-dative, genitive, locative, ablative, and instrumental cases, along with the complex of postpositions that extend this system. His treatment of the 'dative subject' construction — wherein an experiencing subject takes what looks like accusative-dative case marking, while the verb agrees with a non-nominative argument — is particularly sophisticated, and anticipates later work in relational grammar and case theory.

Chapter 4 on pronouns reveals Maithili's most structurally distinctive feature: a four-way honorificity distinction in the second and third person pronoun system (high honorific, honorific, mid-honorific, non-honorific), with the first person being indeterminate as to honorificity. This complexity, for which the standard abbreviations HH, H, MH, and NH are used throughout, is without parallel in the Indo-Aryan family.

### *2.2.4 The Verb and Agreement System: The Central Contribution*

The verbal morphology and agreement system constitute the single most important contribution of the grammar. Chapter 6, the longest in the book, analyses the structure of the verb phrase, verb agreement, causative, compound and conjunct verbs, passive, modal, auxiliary verbs, and non-finite forms.

Yadav's central theoretical claim — elaborated in the grammar (1996) and in his collaborative paper with Gregory Stump (1988) — is that Maithili has a **two-dimensional agreement system**: primary agreement (in which the verb copies the person and honorific features of the subject) and secondary agreement (in which the verb simultaneously encodes the honorific features of the object, or of other participants, through a separate layer of morphology). This produces, at maximum, portmanteau agreement morphemes that encode up to three participants simultaneously — subject, object, and addressee — in a single verbal ending.

This analysis has become a touchstone in the typological literature on agreement. It is cited in cross-linguistic surveys of honorificity by Bickel, Bisang, and Yadava (1999), in formal treatments of allocutive agreement (agreement with the addressee as a non-argument), and in recent minimalist work on left-periphery agreement. Maithili, by virtue of Yadav's description, has entered the canon of languages that challenge the assumption that agreement encodes only nominative subjects.

From the perspective of **Pāṇinian grammar**, Yadav's treatment of agreement morphology engages with the question of *kāraka* — the grammatical roles (*kartā*, agent; *karma*, patient; *sampradāna*, dative; etc.) — and the way verbal endings encode these. Pāṇini's system, as interpreted through the tradition of *aṣṭādhyāyī*, uses *vibhakti* (case endings) and verbal suffixes (*tiṅ*) to encode syntactic role and person/number. Yadav's description shows that Maithili's system extends this beyond the nominative argument, encoding the social relationship between speaker, subject, object, and addressee within the verbal morphology itself — a feature the Pāṇinian tradition did not need to theorize

but which Indian pragmaticists (the *alamkāra* theorists) recognized implicitly in the concept of *vācya* (the matter of speech) and its differential registers.

### *2.2.5 Compound and Conjunct Verbs*

Section 6.5 on compound and conjunct verbs is particularly rich. Yadav identifies a set of *vector verbs* — highly grammaticalized secondary verbs (*jā-* 'go', *le-* 'take', *de-* 'give', *ā-* 'come', *paṛ-* 'fall') — that follow a main verb stem and add aspectual, directional, or evaluative nuance. This analysis contributed to the growing comparative literature on South Asian 'light verb' constructions, and aligns with the general typological insight, made explicit in Haspelmath (1993) and Butt (2003), that complex predicates in South Asian languages encode a systematic interface between lexical semantics and grammatical aspect.

Within the framework of **Bhartrhari's** *Vākyapadīya*, the concept of *sphota* — the unanalysed unity of the sentence as the primary bearer of meaning — is relevant here. Yadav's analysis of compound verbs reveals precisely that the 'meaning' of a Maithili compound verb is not compositional but holistic: the combination of V1 + V2 produces a semantic unit whose sense cannot be predicted from the sum of its parts. Bhartrhari would recognise this as an instance of *vākya-sphota* — sentence meaning that exceeds and precedes its analytical decomposition.

### *2.2.6 Syntax: Word Order, Subordination, and Conditionals*

Chapter 9, on the syntax and semantics of simple and complex sentences, is the culmination of the descriptive project. Yadav establishes Maithili as a consistent SOV (Subject-Object-Verb) language with postpositions, a typological profile consistent with Greenberg's universal correlates for head-final languages (Universal 4: SOV languages tend to have postpositions rather than prepositions). The chapter analyses negation, causativization, passivization, coordination, and subordination in systematic detail.

The treatment of conditional clauses (section 9.6.3.8) is exemplary. Yadav distinguishes 'reality' conditionals (where both clauses are marked for tense in the normal way) from 'counterfactual' or 'unreal' conditionals (where both verbs take the conditional mood marker *-it*), a distinction familiar from the typological literature and from the philosophical tradition of indicative vs. subjunctive conditionals. The Maithili data is illustrated with precisely glossed examples (sentences 1547–1561), providing a basis for formal semantic analysis.

From the perspective of **Navya-Nyāya logic** — the tradition founded by Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya in his *Tattvacintāmaṇi* (14th century) — Yadav's conditional analysis engages implicitly with the Naiyāyika account of *vyāpti* (pervasion, the invariable concomitance that underlies inference). In the Navya-Nyāya framework, a conditional statement of the form 'if p then q' is analysed as a case of *vyāpti* between two properties: whenever the *hetu* (reason) is present, the *sādhya* (probandum) is present. Yadav's data on Maithili conditionals shows that the language encodes this logical distinction morphologically — through the presence or absence of the conditional mood marker — providing empirical material for the Naiyāyika's analysis of valid inference (*anumāna*) and its linguistic expression.

# Part III: Theoretical Frameworks and Critical Appreciation

## 3.1 Western Linguistics: Structural, Generative, and Functional Frameworks

The Videha Issue 396 editorial preface (by Gajendra Thakur) situates Yadav's work explicitly within the comparative framework of traditional, structural, and modern linguistics — drawing on the Chinese comparative paper by Jijian Li and Jiming Li (EMCS 2015), which the journal includes in Maithili translation. This framework maps directly onto the theoretical horizon within which Yadav worked throughout his career.

### *3.1.1 Saussurean Structuralism*

Ferdinand de Saussure's foundational distinctions — *langue/parole*, syntagmatic/paradigmatic, synchronic/diachronic — provide the methodological scaffolding for Yadav's reference grammar. The grammar is explicitly synchronic, describing the structure of Maithili as it was spoken in the late 1970s and 1980s. By choosing synchrony, Yadav aligned his project with the Saussurean programme of structural linguistics, which held that the value of a linguistic element is defined by its systemic relations with other elements, not by its historical derivation.

This is significant because the alternative, the historical-comparative method of Grierson and Hoernle, had consistently subordinated Maithili to its Sanskrit etymons and Magadhi Apabhraṃśa antecedents. By privileging synchrony, Yadav was able to demonstrate that modern Maithili has its own coherent

systemic organization — the honorificity distinctions, the absence of grammatical gender, the compound verb system — that can only be seen clearly when freed from the presupposition that the current state of a language must mirror its historical origin.

### *3.1.2 Generative Grammar and Control Agreement*

In his collaborative paper with Gregory Stump (CLS 1988), Yadav deployed the theoretical machinery of **Lexical-Functional Grammar (LFG)** to analyze Maithili verb agreement within the framework of the 'control agreement principle' developed by Joan Bresnan and colleagues. The paper demonstrated that Maithili's complex secondary agreement could be formally captured within LFG's feature-unification apparatus, and that the phenomena posed interesting challenges to then-prevailing theories of agreement that assumed a single agreement controller (typically the nominative subject).

The broader implications for Chomskyan generative grammar are also significant. Yadav's data shows that the 'nominative island constraint' — the assumption that only nominative subjects trigger agreement — does not hold universally. Maithili is, in this sense, a language that challenges the parameter settings assumed by early Principles-and-Parameters theory, and anticipates the 'free agreement' typology later elaborated in the minimalist programme.

### *3.1.3 Hallidayan Systemic-Functional Grammar*

M.A.K. Halliday's systemic-functional grammar, with its emphasis on language as a social-semiotic resource, provides another lens through which to appreciate Yadav's contribution. For Halliday, grammar simultaneously encodes three meta-functions: ideational (representing the world), interpersonal (enacting social relations), and textual (organizing information). Yadav's analysis of the Maithili honorificity system is, within this framework, an analysis of the **interpersonal meta-function** of Maithili grammar: the complex of agreement morphemes that encodes the social relationships between speaker, subject, and addressee is precisely the grammaticalization of Halliday's 'tenor' of discourse — the power and solidarity relations between interactants.

The sociolinguistic observation noted in Videha Issue 396 — that Yadav was alone among Maithili linguists in paying attention to the *pacpanniyā Maithili* of the lower castes, including the use of 'tõ' (the non-honorific second person) to address 'lower' jāti persons — is, in Hallidayan terms, an observation about the social semiotics of honorificity: the grammar does not merely describe social

hierarchy, it constitutes and reproduces it. Yadav's empirical note (p. 376 of the grammar) that by 1996 the practice of addressing 'lower' jāti people with 'tõ' had begun to change among younger urban speakers marks a sociolinguistic shift in the interpersonal meta-function of Maithili.

### *3.1.4 Fries's Structural Linguistics and Prescriptivism*

The Videha Issue 396 editorial (Gajendra Thakur) explicitly cites Charles Fries's distinction between prescriptive and descriptive grammars, quoting Fries's criticism that 'prescriptive and scholarly grammars belong to a prescientific era.' This citation is placed in direct dialogue with the history of Maithili grammatical tradition, noting that the pedagogical grammarians of Maithili (Ramanath Jha, B. Jha 'Vyathit', D. Jha, Y. Jha) operated within a prescriptive tradition that privileged the Brahmanical 'standard' of Madhubani Maithili over the varieties spoken by other social groups.

Yadav, by contrast, adopts the descriptive stance of modern linguistics: his grammar describes what Maithili speakers of the Terai varieties actually say, not what educated Brahmins of Mithila prescribe. This represents a significant methodological and political choice — one that aligns his work with the democratic and inclusive impulse of Videha's Parallel Literature Movement, which champions the subaltern literary tradition against the Sahitya Akademi canon.

## 3.2 Indian Literary and Grammatical Theory

### *3.2.1 Pāṇini and the Aṣṭādhyāyī Tradition*

The Pāṇinian tradition provides both a foil and a resource for evaluating Yadav's grammar. The *Aṣṭādhyāyī* is the most compact and comprehensive grammar of any natural language in pre-modern times, describing Sanskrit morphology through a system of rules (*sūtra*), metalinguistic abbreviation (*anuvṛtti*), and zero-morpheme analysis that anticipates many features of modern generative phonology and morphology. The Videha editorial (Gajendra Thakur) reflects on the Vaiyākaraṇas' conception of *śabda-brahman* — the notion that language (in its ultimate form) is identical with Brahman, the absolute reality — and traces its four stages: *parā* (undifferentiated), *paśyantī* (visionary), *madhyamā* (intermediate, in the mind), and *vaikharī* (articulated speech).

Yadav's phonetics work engages with the *vaikharī* level — the level of articulated, acoustically measurable speech — through fiberoptic and acoustic

methods. His morphophonemic analysis engages with the interface between *madhyamā* (the cognitive, pre-articulatory representation) and *vaikharī* (the phonetic surface form), a relationship that generative phonology theorizes as the mapping between underlying representation and phonetic output. Yadav's morphophonemic rules — the schwa deletion rule, the a/ā alternation — are, in Pāṇinian terms, *sandhi* rules that operate at the morpheme boundary, though Yadav correctly notes that Maithili sandhi is less extensive than Sanskrit sandhi.

The pedagogical grammarians of Maithili, as Yadav observes, devoted an average of nine pages each to the description of *sandhi* rules — an imposition of the Sanskrit grammatical model on a language whose sandhi processes are minimal. This is precisely the kind of distortion that the Pāṇinian approach, applied without adjustment to a non-Sanskrit language, produces. Yadav's descriptive approach corrects this by treating Maithili morphophonemics on its own terms.

### *3.2.2 Bhartrhari's Philosophy of Language*

Bhartrhari's *Vākyapadīya* (c. 5th century CE) offers a philosophy of language in which the sentence (*vākya*) rather than the word or phoneme is the primary unit of meaning. The concept of *sphota* — the holistic, unanalysed meaning-bearer that underlies the sequence of phonemes — is Bhartrhari's solution to the problem of how sequential sounds can convey unified meaning. The Videha editorial notes that Bhartrhari stands between the Mīmāṃsakas (who prioritize the word) and the Naiyāyikas (who prioritize the sentence), and that Derrida's *grammatology*, while superficially resembling Buddhist conventionalism about language, actually brings Derrida closer to Bhartrhari's grammar-philosophy than to Nāgārjuna.

For Yadav's grammar, the *sphota* doctrine is most relevant in understanding compound and conjunct verbs. As noted above (section 2.2.5), the meaning of a Maithili V1+V2 compound cannot be predicted from the sum of its parts — just as, for Bhartrhari, sentence meaning (*pratibhā*) arises as an immediate flash of understanding that is not analytically derivable from word meanings. Yadav's careful documentation of the semantic nuances of vector verbs (the 'completive', 'adversative', 'benefactive' readings of the same V1 with different V2s) is an empirical contribution to what a *sphota*-theorist would call the description of the *pratibhā* of Maithili compound verbal expressions.

### *3.2.3 The Alaṃkāra Tradition and Honorificity as Rasa*

The *alaṃkāra* (rhetoric and poetics) tradition of Indian literary theory — from Bharata's *Nāṭyaśāstra* through Ānandavardhana's *Dhvanyāloka* and Abhinavagupta's *Abhinavabhāratī* — provides a framework for understanding the social and aesthetic dimensions of Yadav's honorificity analysis. In this tradition, *rasa* (aesthetic emotion/flavour) is evoked through *dhvani* (resonance, suggestive power) — the way a text or utterance carries meanings beyond its literal denotation.

The Maithili honorificity system is, from this perspective, a grammaticalized form of social *dhvani*: every verbal ending in Maithili resonates with social information about the relative status of speaker, subject, object, and addressee. The choice of 'tõ' (non-honorific) versus 'ahāṃ' (high honorific) in addressing an interlocutor is not merely a referential choice but a speech act with affective and social resonance — the grammar itself is a site of *vīra-rasa* (heroic emotion) or *bībhatsa-rasa* (disgust) depending on its social deployment. Yadav's empirical observation that educated young Brahmins in 1996 had begun to stop using 'tõ' to address lower-jāti people is, in this framework, a shift in the social *rasa* of Maithili grammar — a democratic evolution of the language's affective vocabulary.

## 3.3 Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya and Ramawatar Yadav's Linguistics

The Navya-Nyāya school, inaugurated by Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya of Mithila (c. 14th century CE) in his *Tattvacintāmaṇi* (Jewel of Reflection on the Truth about Epistemology), represents the most technically sophisticated system of logical and epistemological analysis in the Indian philosophical tradition. The *Tattvacintāmaṇi* is organized around the four valid means of knowledge (*pramāṇa*): *pratyakṣa* (perception), *anumāna* (inference), *upamāna* (comparison/analogy), and *śabda* (verbal testimony). The fourth section, on *śabda*, is directly relevant to linguistics.

It is a matter of deep cultural significance — noted in the Videha editorial — that both Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya and Ramawatar Yadav emerged from the Mithila region, and that Yadav's grammar of Maithili is, in a sense, the modern scientific counterpart to Gaṅgeśa's philosophical analysis of *śabda-pramāṇa*. Where Gaṅgeśa asked: what are the conditions under which verbal testimony yields valid knowledge? — Yadav asks: what is the structure of the linguistic system that makes verbal communication possible in Maithili?

### *3.3.1 Śabda-Pramāṇa and the Analysis of Meaning*

In Navya-Nyāya, *śabda-pramāṇa* is the valid cognition arising from a reliable speaker's utterance. The analysis of how an utterance conveys meaning involves the technical concepts of *śakti* (the denotative power of a word), *lakṣaṇā* (secondary/metaphorical meaning), and *vyañjanā* (suggestive meaning, important in the *alaṃkāra* tradition). Gaṅgeśa's analysis of the *śabdakhanda* of the *Tattvacintāmaṇi* addresses the relationship between a word-token (*pada*) and its meaning (*padārtha*), taking up the Mīmāṃsaka-Naiyāyika debate on whether the relationship between word and meaning is eternal (*nitya*) or conventional (*aupādhika/ākṛti*).

Yadav's contribution to this debate is indirect but real. His analysis of the Maithili case system and postpositions — showing how the ablative, locative, and genitive meanings are encoded by specific morphemes that may combine with verbs to yield idiomatic meanings not predictable from the sum of their semantic components — is empirical data relevant to the question of *śakti*: what exactly is the semantic 'power' of a morpheme, and how does it compose with others? The Naiyāyika answer — that the denotative power of a word-token is fixed by *smitisamskāra* (habit of use established through prior acquaintance) — is compatible with the distributional approach of structural linguistics, which defines the meaning of a morpheme by its distribution in the language.

### *3.3.2 Anumāna (Inference) and Syntactic Analysis*

The Navya-Nyāya analysis of *anumāna* (inference) proceeds through the identification of *vyāpti* (invariable concomitance): the inference from 'there is smoke on the hill' to 'there is fire on the hill' depends on the established *vyāpti* that wherever there is smoke, there is fire. The Navya-Nyāya logicians developed an extraordinarily precise meta-language (Navya-Nyāya *paribhāṣā*) for expressing these relations, using compounds like *vahninā vyāpya-dhūmatva* (the property of being smoke, which is pervaded by fire) with great technical precision.

Yadav's syntactic analysis, especially his treatment of the conditions governing secondary verb agreement in Maithili, has a structural parallel with Navya-Nyāya inference. His claim that secondary agreement is triggered if and only if specific conditions hold (the object NP being honorific, the subject being third person, the verb being in a specific aspectual form) is logically equivalent to specifying the *vyāpti* that holds between the contextual properties of the utterance and the morphological form of the verb. The technical precision of Yadav's feature specifications — encoded in interlinear glosses such as 'PST-

(3NH + 3H)' — is, in its own way, a formal *paribhāṣā* for Maithili grammar, just as Navya-Nyāya *paribhāṣā* was a formal meta-language for Indian logic.

### *3.3.3 Pratyakṣa (Perception) and Experimental Phonetics*

In the Navya-Nyāya epistemology, *pratyakṣa* (perception) is the most direct form of valid knowledge. Gaṅgeśa's analysis of perception in the first section of the *Tattvacintāmaṇi* distinguishes *nirvikalpaka pratyakṣa* (indeterminate, pre-conceptual perception) from *savikalpaka pratyakṣa* (determinate, conceptually articulated perception). The former is pure sensory awareness without categorization; the latter involves the application of *jāti* (universal/kind) to the perceived particular.

Yadav's experimental phonetics — the fiberoptic study of stop production, the acoustic analysis of vowel nasalization and word stress — operates at the level of *nirvikalpaka pratyakṣa*: it records the physical signal of speech without pre-imposing linguistic categories. The phonemic analysis that follows, identifying the units of the sound system and their distinctive features, corresponds to *savikalpaka pratyakṣa*: the categorization of the perceptual data under linguistic universals (the phoneme, the distinctive feature). This parallelism suggests that Yadav's empirical methodology — ground the abstract in the physical, then ascend to the categorical — follows a logical structure deeply consonant with Navya-Nyāya's graduated epistemology.

# Part IV: Yadav's Place in the History of Maithili Linguistics and Indian Language Studies

## 4.1 Before and After Yadav: A Historiographic Assessment

Prior to Yadav's contributions, Maithili linguistics stood in a peculiar state: grammatically described by colonial administrators (Grierson) through the lens of 'Bihari dialect studies'; historically traced by Subhadra Jha (1958) in the most exhaustive diachronic study to that date; and pedagogically codified by native Brahmanical grammarians whose prescriptivism concealed the language's true structural complexity. None of these traditions had produced a comprehensive, theoretically informed, synchronic description of the entire grammatical system of Maithili.

Yadav's 1996 grammar filled this gap definitively. Within the scholarly literature, it is the standard citation for Maithili grammar: it is cited in the World Atlas of Language Structures (WALS), in comparative surveys of Indo-Aryan languages (Masica 1991, Cardona and Jain 2003), in formal linguistic analyses from minimalism to LFG, and in sociolinguistic studies of language endangerment. It has been the basis for subsequent doctoral dissertations (Bal Krishna Jha, University of Poona, 1984; and many since), and it has shaped the understanding of Maithili in every major reference work in South Asian linguistics.

After the grammar, the field of Maithili linguistics became significantly more sophisticated. Bickel, Bisang, and Yadava (1999) built directly on Yadav's description of the agreement system to develop a cross-linguistic typology of 'face vs. empathy' in verb agreement. Yadava's government-binding thesis (1983/1998) extended the syntactic analysis into transformational-generative territory. Recent minimalist work on allocutive agreement in Maithili cites Yadav's description as foundational data.

The 2024 Videha special issue (Issue 396) adds a further dimension: the reception of Yadav's work in Nepal — including the installation of life-size posters of Yadav alongside Yogendra Prasad Yadav at the New Delhi World Book Fair 2024, in the Language Pavilion — marks the recognition of Yadav's scholarship as a cultural-political achievement for the Maithili-speaking communities of both India and Nepal. In the Videha editorial framework, this

recognition is inseparable from the Parallel Literature Movement's project of restoring the dignity and visibility of Mithila's intellectual heritage.

## 4.2 Sociolinguistic Contribution: Caste, Dialect, and Democratic Linguistics

The sociolinguistic dimension of Yadav's grammar deserves special emphasis. As Subhash Chandra Yadav observes in the collection included in Videha Issue 396, Yadav's grammar is the only major description of Maithili to address — even briefly — the language of the lower-caste communities: the *pacpanniyā Maithili*, the Maithili of the fifty-five artisan and serving jātis of Mithila. The observation (grammar, p. 376) that some uneducated/semi-educated Brahmin youth used 'tõ' to address lower-jāti adults — a form of linguistic caste violence — and that this practice was changing by 1996 represents a rare moment in formal grammar where the social ethics of language use is made explicit.

From the perspective of **critical linguistics** and **language ideology** theory (Woolard and Schieffelin 1994; Irvine and Gal 2000), Yadav's observation can be read as a documentation of *iconization* — the process by which linguistic differences are understood as direct reflections of social distinctions — and its beginning dissolution under conditions of urbanization and social change. The grammar thus serves not only as a description of Maithili structure but as an archive of the social-semiotic conditions of language use in the late twentieth century.

Yadav's article on the sociolinguistics of Maithili (1999) extended this analysis, discussing the internal dialectal variation of Maithili along regional, caste, and socioeconomic lines. His observation that the standard of spoken Maithili is 'tacitly identified with the speech of the towns of Madhubani in Bihar and Rajbiraj in Nepal' is itself a piece of ideological analysis: the 'standard' is the speech of the educated upper-caste urban centres, projected as a neutral norm while erasing the diversity of Maithili as actually spoken by its more than 24 million speakers.

## 4.3 Selected Published Articles (AalekhSanchayan): Key Contributions

The *AalekhSanchayan* (Article Collection) comprises Yadav's published research articles spanning over three decades. Key articles include:

**'Generative Phonology and the Aspirated Consonants of Colloquial Maithili' (1976):** The first application of generative phonological theory to

Maithili, establishing the 'cluster interpretation' of aspirated consonants and demonstrating the inadequacy of earlier 'unit' analyses.

**'A Fiberoptic Study of Stop Production in Maithili' (1979):** Pioneering use of instrumental phonetics for an Eastern Indo-Aryan language, analyzing the laryngeal behaviour of Maithili stop consonants with direct physical evidence.

**'Acoustic Characteristics of Vowel Nasalization in Maithili' (1982):** The first acoustic study of nasalization in Maithili, establishing the measurable phonemic contrast between oral and nasal vowels.

**'Maithili Verb Agreement and the Control Agreement Principle' (with Gregory Stump, 1988):** The theoretical high point of Yadav's syntactic work, demonstrating within LFG that Maithili's complex secondary agreement can be formally captured and that it challenges nominative-centric theories of agreement.

**'Clitic versus Affix: Maithili e and o' (1999):** A nuanced morphosyntactic analysis of the clitics *e* and *o* in Maithili, distinguishing their clitic properties from fully inflectional affixes — a contribution to the typology of clitics across South Asian languages.

**'Maithili' in The Indo-Aryan Languages (ed. Cardona & Jain, Routledge, 2003):** A comprehensive synthesizing chapter that served as the definitive reference article on Maithili for an international audience, presenting the language's phonological, morphological, and syntactic profile within a comparative South Asian context.

**'Maithili Linguistic Research: State-of-the-Art' (2000):** A comprehensive review article charting the entire tradition of Maithili linguistic research, from Grierson through the late 1990s, identifying gaps and setting an agenda for future research.

# Part V: Critical Evaluation — Strengths, Limitations, and Open Questions

## 5.1 Achievements

**Comprehensiveness:** The reference grammar is the most comprehensive description of Maithili ever produced, covering all levels of grammar (phonology, morphology, syntax, semantics) with exemplary detail and hundreds of glossed examples.

**Methodological sophistication:** The combination of experimental phonetics, generative phonology, structural morphology, and syntactic theory places Yadav's work at the intersection of multiple theoretical traditions, ensuring its relevance across research paradigms.

**Cross-linguistic significance:** By placing Maithili's agreement system, phonological system, and syntactic structures in comparative perspective, Yadav's work has contributed to general linguistic typology in ways that extend far beyond the immediate community of Maithili scholars.

**Historical self-awareness:** The opening survey of the grammatical tradition is itself a contribution to the historiography of South Asian linguistics, providing a critical account of both the native Pāṇinian tradition and the colonial Western tradition.

**Sociolinguistic sensitivity:** The attention to caste variation, dialectal diversity, and the politics of standardization, though brief in the grammar, is present and significant, and was extended in the 1999 sociolinguistics article.

## 5.2 Limitations and Open Questions

**Dialect coverage:** The grammar primarily describes the Nepal Terai variety of Maithili, and the Darbhanga variety of Bihar — the most populous dialect region — has been shown in subsequent research (e.g., Kumari 2023) to have agreement restrictions not present in Yadav's description. A full account of Maithili dialectal variation remains to be written.

**Dalit Maithili:** Despite the note at p. 376 regarding caste-based use of pronouns, the grammar does not systematically describe the phonology, morphology, or lexicon of the Dalit varieties of Maithili. As Subhash Chandra Yadav and the Videha editorial board have argued, this gap reflects not a

personal failing of Yadav but the structural constraints of a scholarly tradition that equated 'standard language' with upper-caste urban speech. A grammar of Dalit Maithili remains a major desideratum.

**Pragmatics and discourse:** The grammar is primarily a sentence-grammar, and the discourse-level and pragmatic dimensions of Maithili — topic-comment structure, information packaging, politeness strategies beyond honorificity morphology — are not treated systematically. A Hallidayan systemic-functional grammar of Maithili, building on Yadav's description, would be a significant contribution.

**Lexicography:** Yadav himself identified lexicography as the most neglected area of Maithili linguistics. The vocabulary chapters of the grammar are descriptive rather than comprehensive. A historical dictionary of Maithili — linking the classical vocabulary of Vidyāpati (c. 1360–1448) to the modern language — remains to be compiled.

## Conclusion: The Linguist as Savant and Servant of Language

In the Videha editorial introducing the special issue, Gajendra Thakur describes Yadav as a *niṣkāma karmayogī* (a selfless practitioner of righteous action) for the Maithili language — a figure who, like the ideal described in the *Bhagavadgītā*, acts without attachment to personal reward, dedicating himself to the preservation and scientific description of a threatened linguistic heritage. This characterization, which draws on the deepest resources of the Mithila cultural tradition, captures something essential about Yadav's scholarly ethos.

Seen through Western linguistic theory, Yadav is a structuralist-generativist-phonetician of high competence and wide influence. Seen through the Pāṇinian tradition, he is the modern *vṛttikāra* — the commentator who extends and corrects the inherited grammatical tradition in the light of new evidence and new methods. Seen through the Navya-Nyāya epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya — his great predecessor from the same region — Yadav is an exemplary *pramātā* (knower), one who applies the full range of *pramāṇa* (valid epistemic instruments) — perception (through experimental phonetics), inference (through formal analysis), analogy (through cross-linguistic comparison), and verbal testimony (through the collected speech of Maithili speakers) — to produce valid, well-grounded knowledge of the Maithili language system.

The recognition accorded to Ramawatar Yadav by the Videha Parallel Literature Movement — placing him in the company of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya, Vidyāpati, and the great Mithila savants — is, from the perspective of this critical appreciation, fully warranted. His *A Reference Grammar of Maithili* stands as one of the finest achievements of post-Independence Indian linguistics: a work of scientific rigour, historical depth, and — in its quiet attention to the speech of those previously excluded from the grammatical tradition — genuine democratic commitment.

Future research on Maithili — in phonology, syntax, sociolinguistics, and discourse — will for generations be built on the foundations that Ramawatar Yadav has laid. That is the measure of a truly foundational scholarly contribution.

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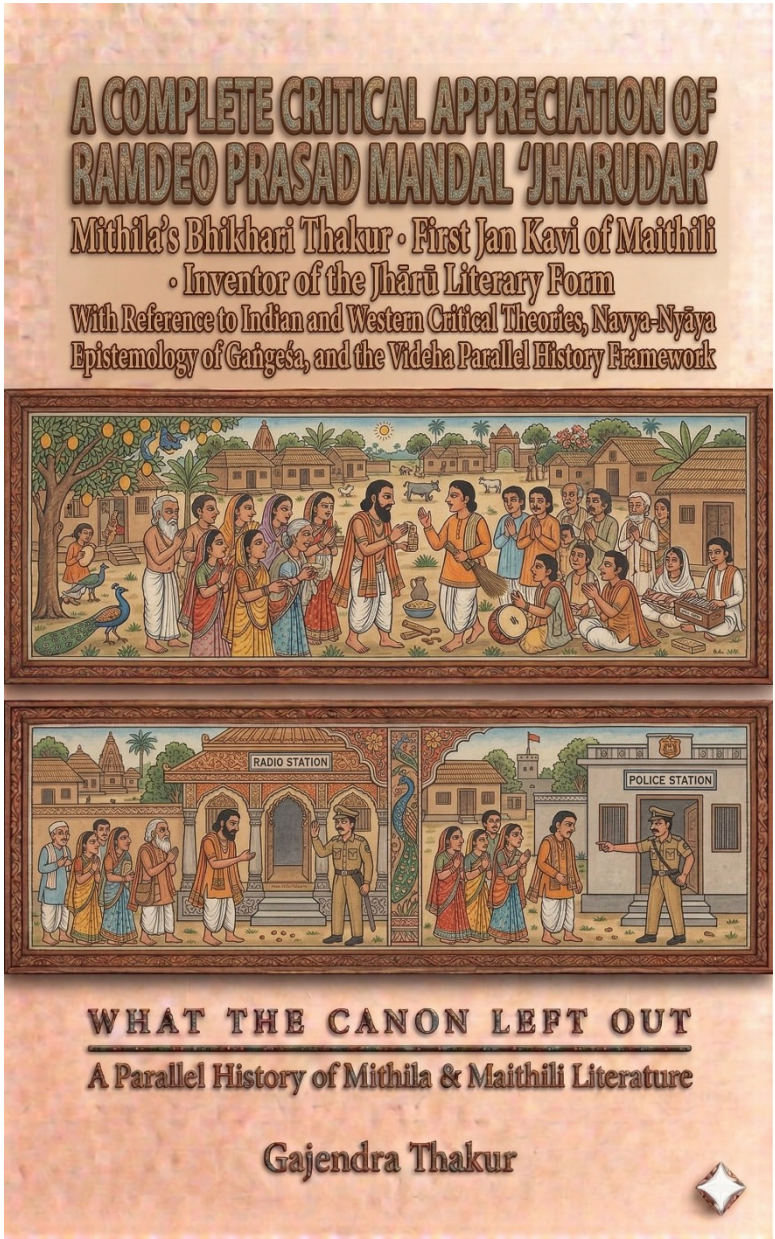
**LESSON 065 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**



# A COMPLETE CRITICAL APPRECIATION OF

# RAMDEO PRASAD MANDAL 'JHARUDAR'

*Mithila's Bhikhari Thakur · First Jan Kavi of Maithili · Inventor of the Jhārū Literary Form*

*With Reference to Indian and Western Critical Theories, Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa, , and the Videha Parallel History Framework*

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## I. PREFATORY NOTE: FRAMING THE APPRECIATION

Ramdeo Prasad Mandal 'Jharudar' occupies a unique position in the landscape of Maithili literature: he is simultaneously inventor, practitioner, and populariser of an entirely new literary genre—the jhārū—and the first writer to be widely recognised as the Jan Kavi ('People's Poet') of Maithili from a non-Brahmin, non-elite social background. Gajendra Thakur, editor of Videha: First Maithili Fortnightly eJournal (ISSN 2229-547X, est. 2000), has titled him 'Mithila's Bhikhari Thakur'—invoking the legendary Bhojpuri playwright-poet Bhikhari Thakur (1887–1971), the low-caste barber who became the most celebrated voice of Bhojpuri folk theatre.

This critical appreciation draws on two primary sources from Jharudar's own pen: Hamara Binu Jagat Sunnaa Chhai (Shruti Publications, New Delhi, 2012; ISBN 978-93-80538-70-9), a collection of gīt (songs) and jhārū poems, and Gatanjali Jharoo (Pallavi Publications, Nirmali, 2018; ISBN 978-93-87675-61-2), his second major anthology. Both texts are examined in light of Indian aesthetics, Western critical theory, and the Navya-Nyāya epistemological methodology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya—the great 13th–14th century Maithili logician whose Tattvacintāmaṇi ('Wish-Fulfilling Gem of Truth') founded the Navya-Nyāya school of Indian logic.

## II. BIOGRAPHICAL INTRODUCTION: THE FARMER-BARD OF MITHILA

Ramdeo Prasad Mandal 'Jharudar' was born into a non-elite, farming family of the Koshi-Kamla-Balan river-belt of Mithila (Bihar), the heartland of the Maithili-speaking world. The pen name 'Jharudar' is itself a literary manifesto: jhārodar means 'one who wields the broom' or 'bearer of the broom,' announced by the invented literary form of the jhārū poem. He lives in and works from the agricultural landscape of Mithila, carrying his poetic compositions on his back as he works the fields, rides a buffalo, and walks the village paths—a compositional practice that Gajendra Thakur describes in his preface (āmukh) to Hamara Binu Jagat Sunnaa Chhai (2012): 'Ramdeo Prasad Mandal Jharudar wanders the forest and the fields, and what he writes spontaneously—that is distinctive; it will be.'

His educational background is limited by the standards of the dominant Maithili literary establishment: he has not received formal higher education in literature or Sanskrit. Yet this 'limitation' is, as Gajendra Thakur recognises,

precisely the ground of his literary power—his Maithili is the Maithili of the people, dense with rural idiom, proverbial wisdom, and lived experiential truth. Thakur notes in his 2012 āmukh that Jharudar 'has invented a new genre in Maithili literature—the jhārū—and no one before him in Maithili (or any other literature) has done this.'

His published work (known from the two volumes under study) spans gīt (lyric songs), jhārū poems (his invented form), and participates in the Videha movement's project of recovering and celebrating the literary voices of Mithila's non-elite communities. Jharudar describes his mother as his first guru: his āmukh poem in Hamara Binu Jagat Sunnaa Chhai opens: 'mā ke smṛti tine / prernā mā-bābūk saṃskārasaṃ prerṭ millai hame ī udes' ('Inspiration—my mother's and father's values directed me to this purpose'). He acknowledges collaboration from Nittu Kumari, Nagendra Thakur, Umesh Mandal, and Gajendra Thakur.

## III. THE INVENTION OF THE JHĀRŪ: A NEW LITERARY FORM

### 3.1 Etymology and Definition

The jhārū (झाड़ू) is the broom—an instrument of sweeping and cleaning. In Mithila, there are multiple kinds of brooms: the kharhā (made of stiff stalks for outdoor sweeping), the phulsokha (the feathery indoor broom), the lāṭhi-jhārū (stiff-stalk broom for clearing refuse). Jharudar's āmukh explains the genre name with characteristic precision: 'Phulsāru se khirihan nahi bahal haet, āu kharṛā se osārā nahi bahāri sakai chhi. Lāṭhime rāhṛik ḍoṭ ke jhāru se jhol-jhāl sāph kayal jāie.' ('You cannot sweep the threshing floor with a soft broom; you cannot sweep the veranda with a coarse one. With the stiff-stalk broom one clears slop and waste.') The jhārū poem, then, is the literary implement specifically designed to sweep away society's slop: its corruption, superstition, casteism, dowry practice, political hypocrisy, and environmental destruction.

### 3.2 Formal Structure of the Jhārū

Each jhārū poem in both collections follows a characteristic bipartite structure. The poem opens with a two-line couplet (the 'jhārū couplet' proper)—a compressed moral or critical statement, often paradoxical or punning, that names the social evil to be swept away. This is followed by a gīt (song) section of multiple stanzas with a refrain, that develops the theme introduced by the couplet. The relationship between the couplet and the song is not merely sequential but epistemological: the couplet poses the problem (the sādhya—the 'to-be-proved' proposition in Navya-Nyāya logical terms) and the song

constructs the argument, adduces the evidence (pramāṇas), and arrives at the conclusion.

Consider the opening jhārū from Hamara Binu Jagat Sunnaa Chhai:

*[Jhārū couplet, poem 1, Hamara Binu Jagat Sunnaa Chhai]*

*ḌUbal hind' ajñān ke sāgar, tapi rahval achi lobh bukhār.*

*Śāśako taṃ bañcit nai dekhābai, ke karatai eṣṭar upacār.*

*(India drowns in the ocean of ignorance, burning with the fever of greed.*

*The rulers cannot see it; who will apply the remedy?)*

This couplet deploys a medical metaphor (bukhār = fever; upacār = treatment) to frame political corruption as a disease, then the song 'Mānav mārai chhai mānavatāke / caṛhi gelair ajñān yau' ('Man kills humanity / ignorance has prevailed') develops the argument through multiple social stanzas.

### 3.3 The Jhārū as Genre Innovation in World Literature

To assess the novelty of the jhārū as a literary form, it is worth situating it within the global taxonomy of poetic forms that combine moral critique with folk-lyric structures. The closest analogues are: (1) the Bhojpuri biraha—a form of separation-lament that Bhikhari Thakur used to social-critical purpose; (2) the Kabir doha—the two-line couplet that distils moral and spiritual wisdom; (3) the Blues form in African-American tradition—a three-line stanza where the first two lines state the problem and the third offers resolution or ironic resignation; (4) the Irish ballad tradition, particularly the political ballad. None of these, however, combines the formal bipartite structure (couplet + song) with the specific naming device (the instrument of social cleansing) that Jharudar has innovated. The jhārū is genuinely original.

## IV. SURVEY OF WORKS

### 4.1 Hamara Binu Jagat Sunnaa Chhai (2012)

Published by Shruti Publications (New Delhi) in 2012, this is Jharudar's first major collection. The title—'Without Me the World Is Empty'—announces the poet's central metaphysical claim: it is the voice of the common Maithili person, the farmer-labourer-woman, that is the world's true content. Without that voice, the world (jagat) is mere vacancy (sunnā). The collection contains a Prārthanā (prayer), a Jhaṇḍā Gīt (flag song celebrating Indian national identity through Mithila's perspective), multiple gīt, and numerous jhārū poems. A

preface (āmukh) by Gajendra Thakur (dated 18 May 2012) establishes the literary-historical significance of the collection and names Jharudar 'Mithila's Bhikhari Thakur.'

The collection is organised thematically: social issues (dowry, superstition, caste), political critique (corrupt politicians and officials), environmental consciousness (deforestation, pollution), women's empowerment, and the pride and pain of Mithila. Thakur's preface notes the philosophical range: 'Now seek in this jhārū the Buddhist philosophy of śūnyavāda and Śaṃkara's advaita philosophy!' — an observation that positions even Jharudar's apparently 'simple' folk poetry within the deepest currents of Indian philosophical thought.

### 4.2 Gatanjali Jharoo (2018)

The second major collection, published by Pallavi Publications (Nirmali, Supaul, 2018), represents a formal deepening of the jhārū project. The title is a compound: gatañjali (from the Sanskrit añjali—an offering with cupped hands—combined here with gat, 'gone/past') + jharoo, suggesting 'the broom offered in memory of what has been lost,' or alternatively 'the sweeping away of the past.' The book is organized into numbered gīt (1–22) followed by thematic jhārū sections: nārī jhārū (brooms on women's issues), bāl jhārū (brooms on children's issues), rājanīti jhārū (political brooms), śikṣā jhārū (educational brooms), paryāvaraṇa jhārū (environmental brooms), sāmpradāyikatā jhārū (communal-harmony brooms), krishi jhārū (agricultural brooms), and bhraṣṭācār jhārū (anti-corruption brooms). This systematic topical organization indicates a mature literary project that is simultaneously poetic and sociological.

## V. THEMATIC AND IDEOLOGICAL ANALYSIS

### 5.1 The Central Assertion: 'Hamara Binu Jagat Sunnaa Chhai'

The title-poem's claim—that without the common person (hamara = us/me) the world is empty—is a political-ontological statement of considerable philosophical depth. It inverts the hierarchy of Mithila's classical literary culture, in which the world derives meaning from the king's patronage, the Brahmin's learning, or the deity's grace. For Jharudar, the world's meaning resides in the labouring, farming, suffering, and resisting masses of Mithila. This is closer to Marx's 'species-being' (Gattungswesen) than to any purely religious frame, though Jharudar expresses it through an idiom saturated with Maithili folk-devotional forms.

*[from poem 1, Hamara Binu Jagat Sunnaa Chhai]*

*Hamara binā ke ī dukh haratai*

*Ahaṃsaṃ ī sabh dānav maratai*

*Kalamakai eka bera pher banābu*

*Rāmak tīr kamān yau.*

*(Without us who will remove this suffering / From us alone all these demons will die /*

*Make the pen once more into / The bow and arrow of Rama, friend.)*

### 5.2 Social Critique: Anti-Superstition, Anti-Dowry, Anti-Casteism

Jharudar's most sustained thematic concern is the liberation of Mithila's people—particularly women and the rural poor—from the triple burden of superstition (andhviśvās), dowry (dahej), and caste hierarchy (jāti-pāti). His anti-superstition poems attack the culture of temple offerings as a substitute for rational action ('Māṃgnese jab devtā daitai / nirghan-niput koi kie rahtai?'—'If prayer alone worked, why would anyone remain childless and poor?'). His dowry poems are among the most passionate and politically clear in the collection:

*[Jhārū on dowry, Hamara Binu Jagat Sunnaa Chhai]*

*Āi har gharame Sītā roai chhai*

*Rāit-rāit bhari nai Janaka sutai chhai*

*Katae saṃ etai dahejak paisā*

*Hetai kenā kanyādān yau.*

*(Today in every home Sita weeps /*

*Night after night, Janaka cannot sleep /*

*From where will the dowry money come /*

*How will the daughter's gift-giving be accomplished?)*

### 5.3 Women's Empowerment: 'Nāri Sītā Rādhā Aṃśa'

Jharudar's women's poetry occupies a distinctive space: it celebrates women's divinity ('Nāri Sītā Rādhā aṃśa / Puruṣa banalair Rāvaṇ kaṃśa'—'Woman is the part of Sita and Radha / Man has become Ravana and Kansa') while simultaneously calling for women's self-assertion, education, and refusal of subjugation. His poem 'Hama miṭhalānī Mithilā ke nāri / rahbai

nai kamajor yau' ('We are Mithila's women / We shall not remain weak') is a declaration of feminist resolve rooted in Maithili folk tradition.

### 5.4 Environmental Consciousness: The Poet as Ecological Activist

One of Jharudar's most distinctive contributions is his sustained attention to environmental degradation. His pollution jhārū poems—on air, water, and sound pollution; on deforestation and the destruction of rivers, lakes, and wetlands—are among the earliest sustained ecologically conscious poetry in Maithili. The jhārū on pollution reads: 'Vijñānak ī den dūṣaṇ / bani ghar ghusal cuhār yau. / Bāgh bani ī muṃh baunel achi / duniyā banal sikār yau.' ('Science's gift, pollution / Has entered the home like a rat / It has opened its tiger-mouth / And the world has become prey.')

### 5.5 Political Critique: Accountability Without Ideology

Jharudar's political poetry is notable for its non-partisan quality: he attacks the systems of corruption (bhraṣṭācār), self-serving governance (lūt), and the exploitation of the poor regardless of which political formation is in power. His poem addressing Bihar's Chief Minister Nitish Kumar—'Kemrāsaṃ tasvīr banebbai / Mithilā maithil parivār ker / Takrā dekhebbai Paṭnā jā kai / Vikās put Nītiśa Kumārake'—is satirical rather than partisan: it offers the photographic evidence of Mithila's underdevelopment (unirrigated fields, broken homes, crumbling infrastructure) as a gift of truth to the 'development son' Nitish Kumar.

## VI. CRITICAL APPRECIATION: WESTERN LITERARY THEORIES

### 6.1 Oral Poetry Theory: Albert Lord and Walter Ong

Albert Lord's foundational study of oral-formulaic poetry (The Singer of Tales, 1960), building on Milman Parry's work on Homeric composition, identified the key features of oral-traditional poetry: the formula (a fixed phrase or hemistich repeated across many poems), the theme (a repeated narrative or descriptive element), and the story-pattern (a recurring structural shape). Jharudar's jhārū poems exhibit all three. His formulas include repeated opening phrases such as 'Sabh banal chhai paisā rogī' ('All have become diseased with money') and 'Jāti dharm mānavatā bhedī' ('Caste-religion divides humanity'); his themes of dowry, superstition, and corruption recur with variation across both collections; his story-pattern of social-problem-stated → cause-analysed → solution-proposed → refrain is the structural backbone of the jhārū form itself.

Walter Ong's Orality and Literacy (1982) identifies the characteristics of oral-tradition thinking as 'additive rather than subordinative, aggregative rather than analytic, situational rather than abstract, empathetic and participatory rather than objectively distanced.' All of these characteristics describe Jharudar's compositional mode: his poems accumulate images additively, they create social solidarity through participatory refrains, they situate critique in specific named social locations (Mithila's farms, its political offices, its dowry-devastated homes), and they invite empathetic engagement through the folk-song form.

### 6.2 Gramsci: The Organic Intellectual and Folk Culture

Antonio Gramsci's concept of the 'organic intellectual' (Prison Notebooks, 1929–35)—the intellectual who emerges from within a subaltern class and develops the class's own self-consciousness—is precisely applicable to Jharudar. Unlike the 'traditional intellectual' who is divorced from production and claims universal authority, the organic intellectual speaks from within the productive community. Jharudar's identity as a farmer who composes poetry on his buffalo's back, on field boundaries, and on village paths, is not incidental to his literary authority but constitutive of it. He is Mithila's rural working community thinking through the medium of art.

Gramsci also wrote extensively on folklore as a 'conception of the world' of the subaltern classes—not a merely decorative survival but a coherent (if fragmentary and unsystematic) world-view that exists in tension with the dominant 'official' culture. Jharudar's jhārū form is precisely such a folkloric world-view given systematic literary shape: it draws on the existing resources of Maithili folk song (the gīt form, the refrain structure, the communal mode of address) and inflects them with a consistent critical consciousness.

### 6.3 Bertolt Brecht and the Didactic Function of Folk Art

Bertolt Brecht's theory of Epic Theatre—with its insistence on the pedagogical function of drama, its Verfremdungseffekt (estrangement effect), and its direct address to the audience as rational agents rather than passive emotional subjects—finds a striking parallel in Jharudar's jhārū mode. Brecht wanted theatre to make the audience think, not merely feel; to see the social world as changeable rather than natural. Jharudar's jhārū couplets operate precisely as estrangement devices: they defamiliarise the familiar social evil (dowry, superstition, corruption) by naming it with a sharp, often punning phrase that makes it appear strange and therefore criticisable. The question at the end of each jhārū refrain—'ke karatai eṣṭar upacār?', 'hetai kenā navakā

vihān?'—functions exactly as Brecht's gestus: a physical or linguistic gesture that crystallises the social meaning of a situation.

### 6.4 Feminist Literary Theory: Adrienne Rich and the Politics of Location

Adrienne Rich's concept of 'the politics of location' (Blood, Bread, and Poetry, 1986) argues that all literary knowledge is situated—produced from within a specific body, geography, and social position—and that this situatedness is not a limitation to be transcended but the ground of authentic literary authority. Jharudar's nārī jhārū poems speak from a politics of location that is simultaneously inside and outside women's experience: as a man from a marginalised community, he writes about women's oppression with deep empathetic understanding but also with a solidarity that recognises the structural parallels between caste-oppression and gender-oppression. His poem 'Nārī sītā rādhā aṃśa / Puruṣa banalair rāvaṇ kaṃśa' is a feminist analysis conducted through the idiom of the Maithili cultural imaginary.

### 6.5 Bakhtin: The Carnivalesque and Folk Humour

Mikhail Bakhtin's analysis of the carnivalesque in Rabelais and His World (1965) and the concept of dialogism in The Dialogic Imagination (1981) illuminate the social function of Jharudar's comic-satirical mode. Bakhtin describes the carnival as a temporary inversion of social hierarchy in which the body, laughter, and popular language overthrow official culture. Jharudar's jhārū poems perform exactly this carnivalesque function: they use the popular folk-song form, the earthy rural imagery (buffalo, broom, field, latrine), and vigorous satirical humour to expose and ridicule the pretensions of Mithila's social and political elite. The broom is itself a carnivalesque instrument: associated with the lowest social labour (sweeping, cleaning), it is wielded here to strip the powerful of their dignity.

### 6.6 Postcolonial Theory and the Vernacular

Ngugi wa Thiong'o's argument in Decolonising the Mind (1986) for writing in African vernacular languages as an act of cultural self-determination finds a precise Maithili parallel in Jharudar's insistence on composing entirely in Maithili. He does not aspire to Hindi, English, or Sanskrit legitimation; his literary authority is claimed through the vernacular itself. This is a specifically postcolonial linguistic politics: the refusal to use the colonial or elite language as the medium of one's literary ambition.

## VII. CRITICAL APPRECIATION: INDIAN AESTHETICS, NĀṬYAŚĀSTRA, AND RASA THEORY

### 7.1 Bharata's Nāṭyaśāstra: Rasa in the Jhārū Poems

Bharata Muni's Nāṭyaśāstra (c. 200 BCE–200 CE) defines the aesthetic experience of art through the concept of rasa—the 'juice' or 'flavour' that a work produces in the cultivated reader/spectator through the alchemical combination of vibhāva (stimulant/cause), anubhāva (consequent/response), and vyabhicāribhāva (transitory emotions). Jharudar's jhārū poems are rich in rasa, though the rasas they evoke are not the dominant courtly rasas (śṛṅgāra, vīra) but the socially critical ones:

**Karuṇa rasa (pathetic/compassionate):** The dominant rasa of the women's and poverty poems. The vibhāva is the specific social condition described (the Sita who weeps every night for want of dowry money; the 'sick world' where children labour while passengers debate child labour). The anubhāva is the reader's compassionate sorrow. This rasa is sustained without sentimentality by Jharudar's refusal of melodrama.

**Raudra rasa (furious/wrathful):** The jhārū poems on corruption and political hypocrisy evoke controlled anger (raudra)—not the uncontrolled fury that Bharata associates with villains, but the righteous anger of the social critic who refuses to be silenced.

**Hāsya rasa (comic/ironic):** Jharudar's satirical mode produces a particular kind of hāsya—not mere laughter but the bitter comedy of recognition, close to what Bergson (in Le Rire, 1900) identified as laughter at the mechanical encrusted on the living. His political satire is rich in this double-edged comedy.

**Bībhatsa rasa (disgusting/grotesque):** The pollution poems and the dowry poems use elements of the disgusting (bībhatsa) to estrange the reader from social evils that familiarity has normalised: 'Vijñānak ī den dūṣaṇ / bani ghar ghusal cuhār yau' ('Science's gift pollution / has entered the home like a rat').

**Vīra rasa (heroic):** The women's empowerment poems and the calls for social solidarity evoke a 'subaltern vīra'—not the warrior-king's heroism but the heroism of the ordinary person who claims dignity and refuses subjugation. 'Āba nai nārī rahab anārī / banabai saktī kaṭhor yau' ('Now women will not remain illiterate / We will become strong and firm').

### 7.2 Dhvani Theory: The Resonant Unsaid

Ānandavardhana's Dhvanyāloka (c. 850 CE) argues that the highest literary achievement consists not in what is directly stated (vācya) but in what is suggested (dhvani)—the resonant unstated meaning. While Jharudar's poems are notably more direct than the dhvani-rich classical Sanskrit poetry (a

directness appropriate to his folk-oral mode), his best jhārū couplets achieve remarkable suggestive power. The couplet 'Jāi gharame hoī nārī pūjā / O ghar hoi chhai svarg samān. / Oi gharake taṃ naraike mānu / Jetae hoī nārik apamān' ('The home where women are worshipped / Is like heaven. / Consider that home hell / Where women are dishonoured') achieves its force not through its explicit comparison but through its dhvani: the implication that most homes are hell, that Mithila's reality is the second stanza not the first.

### 7.3 Loka Dharma and the Nāṭyaśāstra's Social Register

Bharata's Nāṭyaśāstra stipulates that drama should serve the dharma of the loka (people)—it should instruct, entertain, and reform. The Nāṭyaśāstra's fourteenth chapter identifies the four purposes of drama as dharma, artha, kāma, and mokṣa (right conduct, wealth, pleasure, and liberation). Jharudar's jhārū poems operate squarely within the dharma and artha registers: they teach right social conduct (dharma) by exposing wrong conduct, and they address the artha concerns of Mithila's people (poverty, dowry, governmental corruption, agricultural distress). The kāma and mokṣa registers are less prominent—Jharudar is not a mystical poet like Kabir or Vidyapati—but his prayer poem (Prārthanā) reaches toward mokṣa in its aspiration for a world freed from ignorance and greed.

### 7.4 The Kabir Tradition and the Doha Form

Jharudar's jhārū couplets are structurally related to the doha tradition—the two-line aphoristic verse form used by Kabir (1398–1518) to combine spiritual and social critique. Kabir's dohas achieved their devastating effect through paradox, surprise, and semantic compression; Jharudar's jhārū couplets achieve similar effects through a different formal strategy—the naming of a specific social instrument (the broom), the precision of its deployment against a named social evil, and the promise of the song that follows. Like Kabir, Jharudar works in a vernacular idiom accessible to those without Sanskrit or formal literary education; like Kabir, he critiques both Hindu orthodoxy (mandir-centred superstition) and social hierarchy (caste and gender); and like Kabir, his poetry circulates orally among people who would never enter a library or literary seminar.

## VIII. NAVYA-NYĀYA EPISTEMOLOGY OF GAṄGEŚA UPĀDHYĀYA APPLIED TO JHARUDAR'S POETRY

### 8.1 Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya: The Logician from Jharudar's Own Land

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (fl. 13th–14th century CE) was a native of Mithila—the same geographical and cultural world that produced Jharudar. His

Tattvacintāmaṇi ('Wish-Fulfilling Gem of Truth') founded the Navya-Nyāya school of Indian epistemology and logic, developing an extraordinarily precise technical vocabulary for analysing the conditions under which a cognition (jñāna) constitutes valid knowledge (pramā). As documented in Gajendra Thakur's Parallel History of Maithili Literature and in Videha's coverage, Gaṅgeśa's own social biography was marginalised within the dominant Brahmin culture of medieval Mithila—he married a woman of the artisan (charmakāriṇī) community and was regarded as 'inferior in social status.' This structural parallel between Gaṅgeśa and Jharudar—both producing foundational intellectual work from outside the socially dominant community—is not merely biographical but literary-philosophical.

### 8.2 The Jhārū as Pramāṇa: Four Sources of Valid Knowledge

Navya-Nyāya recognises four pramāṇas (sources of valid cognition): pratyakṣa (perception), anumāna (inference), upamāna (analogy), and śabda (verbal testimony). Jharudar's jhārū poems can be analysed as operating through all four:

**Pratyakṣa (Direct Perception):** Jharudar's poems are grounded in observed social reality—the broken house, the weeping Sita, the polluted river, the corrupt official. His authority derives from having seen, having experienced directly, what he reports. The poem on Bihar's unirrigated fields and power-cut villages—'Foṭo banebai khet asiṃcit / Siṃcāi pāni bijlīsaṃ vañcit'—is the report of a witness who has perceived directly.

**Anumāna (Inference):** The jhārū form's bipartite structure—couplet (problem) → song (analysis)—enacts a movement of anumāna: from the observed sign (liṅga) of social evil to the inferred cause (vyāpaka) of structural injustice. The reader is invited to follow this inferential movement.

**Upamāna (Analogy):** Jharudar's metaphors are sophisticated upamānas. The medical metaphor (politics as disease, ajñāna as fever, dowry as a 'shroud covering all'), the ecological metaphor (pollution as a rat entering the home, then a tiger devouring the world), and the cosmic metaphor (the empty world without the common person) are all upamānas that generate valid knowledge by comparing the unfamiliar (the structural nature of social evil) to the familiar (bodily illness, animal predation, cosmic vacancy).

**Śabda (Verbal Testimony):** Jharudar's poems also function as śabda pramāṇa—valid testimony from a reliable source. His authority as a witness-from-within (a farmer, not an outside observer) gives his verbal testimony a different quality from that of the 'official' literary culture. Navya-Nyāya distinguishes

between the testimony of a reliable speaker (āptavacana) and unreliable speech (anāptavacana). Jharudar's entire poetic project is an argument that the āpta (reliable witness) of Mithila's social reality is the person who lives it, not the person who theorises it from outside.

### 8.3 Vyāpti and the Universal Claim of the Folk Poem

Navya-Nyāya's concept of vyāpti—universal concomitance, the relationship of invariable co-occurrence between a property and its sign—is central to the validity of inference. In logical terms: if wherever there is smoke there is fire (vyāpti), then the presence of smoke (liṅga) is a valid reason to infer fire (sādhya). Applied to Jharudar's poetry: the jhārū poem achieves literary power precisely when the specific instance it depicts achieves vyāpti—when the particular dowry-weeping Sita becomes the sign of a universal condition affecting all Maithili households. The best jhārū couplets are those in which the specific collapses into the universal: 'Āi har gharame Sītā roai chhai' ('Today in every home Sita weeps') is already a universalisation—har ghara, every home—that enacts vyāpti.

### 8.4 Śūnyavāda and Advaita in 'Hamara Binu Jagat Sunnaa Chhai'

Gajendra Thakur's preface to the 2012 collection explicitly invites the reader to find 'Buddhist śūnyavāda and Śaṃkara's advaita philosophy' in the title poem's claim: 'hamara binu jagat sunnā chhai' ('without me the world is empty'). Thakur's reading is philosophically acute. In Mādhyamika Buddhist śūnyavāda, all phenomena are empty (śūnya) of inherent self-existence—they exist only in interdependence. Jharudar's claim that the world is sunnā (empty) without the common person inverts this: it asserts that the world's content, its non-emptiness, is constituted by the presence and work of the subaltern. In Advaita Vedānta, Ātman and Brahman are non-dual—individual consciousness and universal consciousness are the same reality. Jharudar's 'hamara' (us/me) claims to be the Brahman of the social world: the universal constitutive ground without which the particular phenomena of social life (governance, culture, religion) would collapse into sunnā.

## IX. COMPARATIVE STUDY: JHARUDAR AMONG MAITHILI WRITERS

### 9.1 Jharudar and Vidyapati (c. 1352–1448): Continuity and Counter-Tradition

Vidyapati, the great medieval poet of Mithila, wrote his padāvalī in the śṛṅgāra (erotic-devotional) rasa, in a richly Sanskritised Maithili patronised by the Karnāṭa dynasty. Jharudar could not be further from this model in social

location, audience, linguistic register, rasa, and purpose. Yet there is a deep continuity: both poets are rooted in the Maithili language's musical and lyrical traditions, both deploy a refrain-structure that invites communal participation, and both address their poetry to a named social world (Mithila). The difference is one of who the world belongs to: for Vidyapati, Mithila is the world of divine love and courtly culture; for Jharudar, Mithila is the world of the farmer's flood-damaged field and the woman's dowry-terror.

### 9.2 Jharudar and Harimohan Jha (1908–1984): The Social Satirist's Lineage

Harimohan Jha's Khattar Kakak Tarang is Maithili's foundational social-satirical prose work, attacking Brahmin orthodoxy from within. Jharudar attacks the same orthodoxy—superstition, caste hierarchy, dowry—from outside: as a non-elite farmer. The difference in social location produces different literary modes: Jha used the sophisticated irony of the insider who knows the system's absurdities; Jharudar uses the direct indignation and the folk form of the person who suffers the system's consequences.

### 9.3 Jharudar and Jagdish Prasad Mandal (b. c. 1952): Two OBC/Farmer Writers

Jagdish Prasad Mandal, recipient of the Sahitya Akademi Award 2021 for his novel Pangu (2018), shares with Jharudar the social location of a non-Brahmin farming community and the commitment to representing Mithila's subaltern voices. But their literary modes are opposite: Mandal writes in social-realist prose fiction (novels, short stories), while Jharudar writes in the folk-lyric mode of the jhārū poem and the gīt. Together, they represent complementary dimensions of the democratisation of Maithili literature: Mandal providing depth of character and narrative, Jharudar providing breadth of communal address and formal innovation.

### 9.4 Jharudar and Umesh Mandal (Videha's Artist-Lexicographer): Folk Traditions

Umesh Mandal, associated with the Videha movement, has contributed picture-dictionaries of Mithila's flora, fauna, and traditional crafts to the archive. His work is lexicographical; Jharudar's is lyrical. But both operate from the same conviction: that the knowledge most worth preserving and celebrating is the knowledge embedded in the daily practices and languages of Mithila's non-elite communities.

## X. JHARUDAR AND BHIKHARI THAKUR: THE JAN KAVI TRADITION

The comparison with Bhikhari Thakur (1887–1971) is not merely an epithet coined by Gajendra Thakur for promotional effect; it is a structurally precise characterisation that illuminates both figures.

### 10.1 Parallel Biographies: Caste, Labour, and Literary Invention

Bhikhari Thakur was born into the Nāī (barber) caste—a service caste regarded as socially inferior in the Brahmin-dominated cultural hierarchy of Bihar. He was largely self-taught and composed his first plays while working as a barber and later as a performer. Jharudar is from a farming community that similarly occupies a non-elite social position in Mithila's hierarchy. Both men used their social marginality as literary resource: their intimate knowledge of the lives of the rural poor, the women left behind by migrating husbands, the victims of dowry and caste violence, gave their work an authority that no amount of formal education could have produced.

Bhikhari Thakur was called 'Shakespeare of Bhojpuri' by Rahul Sankrityayan—a comparison that (as Theatre Times' analysis notes) captures his theatrical range and his ability to blend religious, secular, tragic, and comic elements into a distinctive folk theatre. Jharudar is called 'Mithila's Bhikhari Thakur' by Gajendra Thakur—a comparison that captures his invention of a new form, his social-critical purpose, and his rootedness in his community's daily life.

### 10.2 The Jan Kavi: A Structural Role

The 'Jan Kavi' (People's Poet) is not merely a popular poet; it is a structural role in the literary ecology of a community. The Jan Kavi is the one who voices what the community knows but has not articulated in literary form; who holds up a mirror (to use Hamlet's phrase) that is not the polished silver of the educated class but the clean water of the common stream. In Bhojpuri, Bhikhari Thakur performed this role through drama and song (his Bidesiya giving voice to the wives of migrant labourers, his Beti Biyog to the grief of daughters given away in marriage). In Maithili, Jharudar performs the same structural role through the jhārū and gīt, giving voice to Mithila's women, farmers, and socially marginalised communities.

Both Jan Kavis also addressed the systematic social problems of their regions: child marriage, dowry, gender inequality, casteism, and the exploitation of the poor by the powerful. Both did so through forms accessible to illiterate and semi-literate audiences—not through the difficult formal verse of the Sanskrit-trained literary tradition but through the melodic, participatory structures of folk song.

### 10.3 Differences: Theatre vs. Lyric, Migration vs. Soil

The most significant difference between Bhikhari Thakur and Jharudar is the literary medium. Bhikhari Thakur was primarily a dramatist-performer: his Bidesiya, Beti Biyog, Vidhva Vilap, and other plays were performed on open stages with music, dance, and improvisation. As Theatre Times notes, 'In folk theatre, with its flexible structure that provides space for improvisation and experimentation, the text is constantly rewritten in the hands of actors and musicians.' Bhikhari Thakur's texts were living, performance-dependent entities. Jharudar, by contrast, is a lyric poet: his jhārū poems and gīt exist in fixed written form (published by Shruti Publications and Pallavi Publications) even as they draw on oral-folk conventions. The second difference is thematic: Bhikhari Thakur's central theme is migration (Bidesiya = the one who has gone abroad), the pain of separation, and the destruction of the village community by the city's pull. Jharudar's central theme is the soil itself—the farm, the river, the flood, the village's political life—not the migrant's journey but the stayer's resistance.

## XI. JHARUDAR AND NAGARJUNA (YATRI): TWO 'PEOPLE'S POETS' COMPARED

The comparison of Jharudar with Nagarjuna (Vaidyanath Mishra, 1911–1998)—Maithili's most celebrated Jan Kavi, known as 'Yatri' in his Maithili work and 'Nagarjun' in his far more extensive Hindi writing—illuminates both the continuity and the radical difference between the two generations of Maithili populist poetry.

### 11.1 The Janakavi Title: Nagarjuna's Legacy and Jharudar's Claim

Nagarjuna was universally acknowledged as Janakavi ('People's Poet') in both Hindi and Maithili. Born into a Maithil Brahmin family, he educated himself in Sanskrit, Pali, Prakrit, Hindi, and Bengali; converted to Buddhism (taking the name Nagarjuna, after the great Mādhyamika philosopher); immersed himself in Marxist ideology; and became the wandering bard of progressive India—the 'Yatri' (Traveller) of Maithili and the revolutionary voice of Hindi progressive literature. He received the Sahitya Akademi Award (1968/1969) for his Maithili work Patrahin Nagna Gachh ('The Leafless Naked Tree').

Jharudar's claim to the Janakavi title operates on entirely different grounds: not the intellectual breadth and political-historical range of Nagarjuna, but the rootedness in a specific local community and the invention of a specific local form. If Nagarjuna's poetry is the bird's-eye view—surveying

all of India's political and social landscape from the altitude of a widely travelled, widely read revolutionary intellectual—Jharudar's poetry is the worm's-eye view: the perspective from within the Mithila soil, seeing only what the farmer in the field can see, but seeing it with unsurpassable intimacy and precision.

### 11.2 Language and Social Location

The most fundamental difference is social location and its linguistic consequence. Nagarjuna was a Maithil Brahmin whose dominant literary medium was Hindi; his Maithili work, while genuine and celebrated, was never the primary vehicle of his literary ambition. As Wikipedia's entry notes, 'Hindi remained the language of the bulk of his literature.' This means that Nagarjuna's relationship to Maithili was that of the highly educated native speaker who chooses to write partly in his mother tongue while conducting his major literary career in the dominant national language. Jharudar writes exclusively in Maithili, from a community that has no access to Hindi literary prestige, and with a formal invention (the jhārū) that could not have been achieved in any other language. His Maithili is not a choice but a necessity—and that necessity is his literary strength.

### 11.3 Ideology and Form

Nagarjuna's poetry is explicitly ideological in the Marxist-progressive tradition: his poems engage with the Emergency, the JP Movement, the Bihar peasant struggle, and the international left. His satire is politically sophisticated and often intellectually demanding—requiring knowledge of history, politics, and literary allusion. Jharudar's ideology, by contrast, is not imported from Marxism or any formal political philosophy; it is an indigenous social ethics rooted in the values of rural Mithila—the dignity of labour, the equality of all persons before the divine (his prayer poem invokes a God who heals all), and the specific grievances of Mithila's women, farmers, and poor.

In formal terms, Nagarjuna's best poetry is characterised by a mastery of both classical Sanskrit metres and free verse, intellectual density, and satirical wit of a literary rather than folk character. Jharudar's jhārū form is structurally simpler but sociologically more specific—it is designed for oral performance, communal participation, and immediate social application. Each represents a different relationship between literary form and social function.

## XII. RECEPTION AND LEGACY

Ramdeo Prasad Mandal Jharudar's reception history is small in the institutional sense—no major literary prize has been awarded to him, no entry

in mainstream literary histories of Maithili—but significant in the 'parallel literature' framework established by Videha. Gajendra Thakur's preface to Hamara Binu Jagat Sunnaa Chhai (2012) is the most substantial critical assessment of his work to date and constitutes the entry of his work into Maithili's critical discourse.

Thakur's assessment emphasises three dimensions of Jharudar's significance: (1) formal innovation—the invention of the jhārū as a new genre in Maithili and in Indian literature generally; (2) social function—the sweeping of social evils through the broom-poem, making literature directly applicable to community life; and (3) philosophical depth—the Buddhist and Advaita resonances of his central metaphysical claim. These three dimensions together constitute Jharudar's literary legacy within the Videha movement's project of parallel Maithili literature.

His work has been distributed through Videha's networks, through Pallavi Distributors (Nirmali, Supaul), and through the oral circulation of folk performance. His songs (gīt) have circulated beyond the literary sphere into community events, as the folk-song form naturally does. The Gatanjali Jharoo (2018) represents a further deepening and systematisation of the jhārū project, suggesting a continuing creative development.

## XIII. CONCLUSIONS: LITERARY SIGNIFICANCE AND THE JHĀRŪ'S FUTURE

Ramdeo Prasad Mandal 'Jharudar' occupies a singular position in the history of Maithili literature for reasons that this appreciation has sought to demonstrate: the invention of the jhārū as a genuinely new literary form; the occupation of the Jan Kavi role from a social location (non-elite farming community) that had never previously held that position in Maithili; the systematic application of literary art to social critique across the full range of Mithila's contemporary problems; and the sustained maintenance of folk-lyric beauty in the service of radical social content.

From the perspective of Western literary theory, Jharudar is an organic intellectual in the Gramscian sense, a practitioner of folk humour in the Bakhtinian sense, and a postcolonial vernacular poet in the tradition of Ngugi wa Thiong'o. From the perspective of Indian aesthetics, his primary rasas are karuṇa, raudra, and hāsya; his best poems achieve the dhvani of structural critique beneath the surface of folk-lyric simplicity; and his prārthanā poem aspires toward the śānta rasa of universal human dignity. From the perspective of Navya-Nyāya epistemology, his jhārū form operates through all four

pramāṇas—pratyakṣa, anumāna, upamāna, and śabda—and achieves vyāpti when its specific social observations generate universally recognisable truths.

The jhārū as a literary form has genuine potential beyond Jharudar's own work. Its bipartite structure (critical couplet + elaborative song), its instrument-metaphor (the broom as social critique), and its topical organisation (one broom for each social evil) constitute a flexible template that other Maithili poets could adopt and adapt. The systematic thematic organisation of Gatanjali Jharoo—with its nārī jhārū, rājanīti jhārū, paryāvaraṇa jhārū, etc.—suggests the possibility of a jhārū literature that addresses the full range of Maithili society's concerns in a form accessible to its widest possible readership. Whether this potential is realised depends on whether the Maithili literary establishment—mainstream and parallel alike—recognises and engages with the significance of Jharudar's innovation.

*Hamara binā ke ī dukh haratai / Ahaṃsaṃ ī sabh dānav maratai.* — Ramdeo Prasad Mandal 'Jharudar', Hamara Binu Jagat Sunnaa Chhai (2012)

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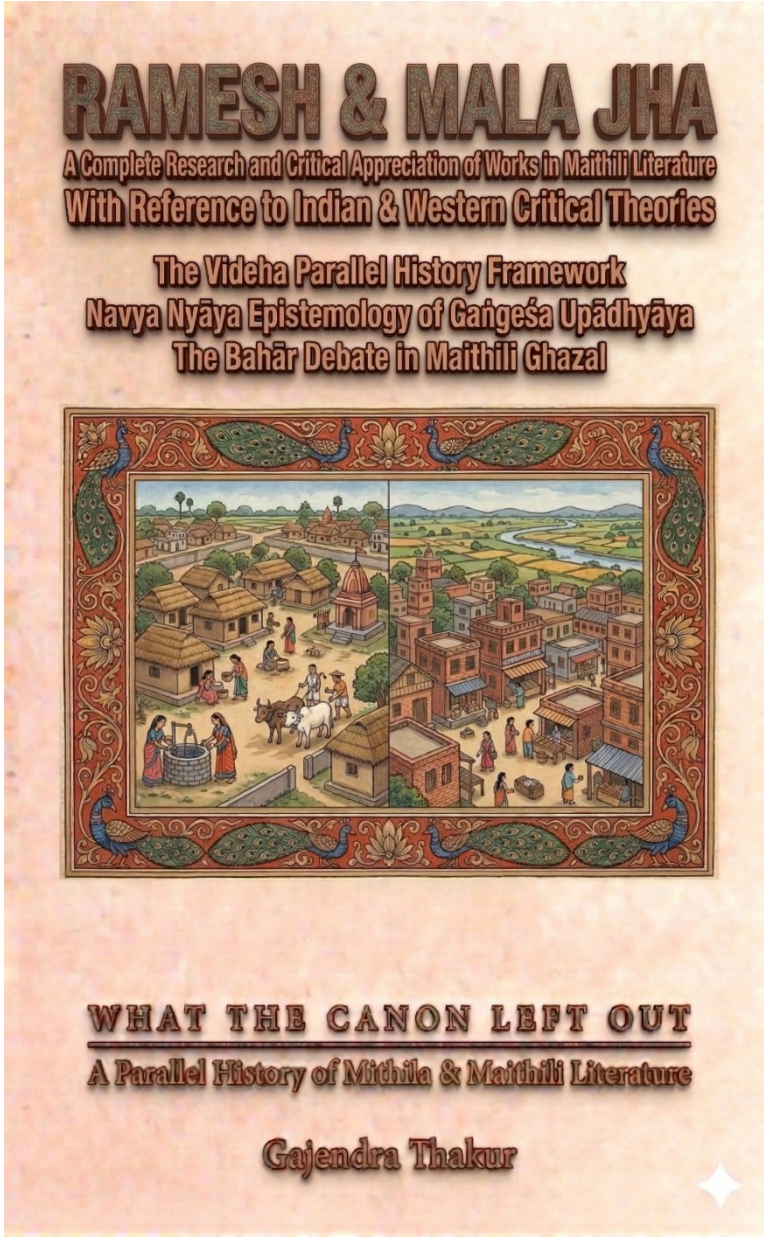

# RAMESH A Complete Research and Critical Appreciation of Works in Maithili Literature

**RAMESH & MALA JHA**

*A Complete Research and Critical Appreciation*

of Works in Maithili Literature

*With Reference to Indian & Western Critical Theories*

*The Videha Parallel History Framework*

*Navya Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya*

*The Bahār Debate in Maithili Ghazal*

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## 1. Preface: The Significance of Ramesh in Maithili Literature

Maithili — one of the twenty-two constitutionally recognised languages of India and a language whose written literary tradition stretches back to the Charyāpadas of the Buddhist Siddhas, the lyric genius of Vidyapati Ṭhakkura (c. 1352–1448), and the philosophical rigour of Vācaspati Miśra (c. 900–980 CE), philosopher of the Navya Nyāya lineage — has in the contemporary period produced a remarkable body of prose fiction, poetry, and literary criticism. Within this landscape, the writer known simply as Ramesh occupies a position that is simultaneously central and quietly subversive. Working across the major literary genres — the short story, the poem, the literary essay, and the long verse-form — Ramesh has contributed works of sustained imaginative power whose significance has only recently begun to receive systematic critical attention.

This research and critical appreciation undertakes that task systematically. It draws on the primary texts published by Navarambh Prakashan — the story collections Samanantar and Samang (brought together as Katha-Samay, 2020), the poetry omnibus Kavita-Samay (2020), the long verse Kavya Dwipak: Ohi Par, and the critical collection Nikti (2018) — as well as the volume of scholarly essays Ramesh: Mandan aur Mishra, a compilation of critical responses by several scholars. It also draws on the rich archival resources of Videha (www.videha.co.in), the First Maithili Fortnightly eJournal (ISSN 2229-547X), edited by Gajendra Thakur, which has been a key platform for the dissemination and discussion of Ramesh's work.

The study employs a multi-layered critical framework. Indian literary theory — Bharata Muni's Nāṭyaśāstra, Ānandavardhana's dhvani theory, Abhinavagupta's rasa-dhvani synthesis, Kuntaka's vakrokti, and Kṣemendra's aucitya — is brought into dialogue with the epistemological protocols of Navya Nyāya as established by Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya of Mithila in his Tattvacintāmaṇi. Western critical traditions — phenomenology, structuralism, post-colonial theory, and intertextuality — complete the analytical apparatus. A special section is devoted to the Bahār debate in Maithili Ghazal, a controversy directly relevant to the formal choices visible in Ramesh's poetic practice.

The Videha Parallel History Framework — articulated by Gajendra Thakur in the ongoing Parallel History section of the Videha eJournal — provides the historiographical context within which Ramesh's position as part of the 'parallel stream' of Maithili literature (distinct from the caste-dominated mainstream) is examined.

## 2. Biographical Context and Literary Career

Ramesh writes in the Maithili language and has published across multiple genres with Navarambh Prakashan (Navarambh, 63 Todar Mal Road, Area 77, Patna – 800020; email: navarambhprakashan@gmail.com). While the author has maintained a deliberate restraint regarding public biographical disclosure — a stance consonant with his artistic philosophy of allowing the work to speak for itself — the publication histories of his five identified major works, the email address lekhakajitazad@gmail.com associated with his writings, and the critical responses collected in Ramesh: Mandan aur Mishra allow the contours of a literary biography to be traced.

Ramesh's sustained literary output spans at least the period from the mid-2010s to 2020, with Nikti (criticism) appearing in 2018 and the two substantial creative volumes Katha-Samay and Kavita-Samay appearing in 2020. The Kavya Dwipak: Ohi Par verse collection represents another dimension of his creative range. That all of this work was made available through the Videha archive — the largest digital repository of Maithili literary texts — places Ramesh within the Videha literary movement's orbit, characterised by its commitment to democratising Maithili writing beyond traditional caste gatekeeping, its openness to non-Brahmin and non-Kayastha voices, and its embrace of modernist and experimental literary modes.

The critical volume Nikti (meaning 'touchstone' or 'criterion' — a term with deep resonances in Sanskrit poetics through the metaphor of the nikaṣa-pāṣāṇa or touchstone by which gold is tested) immediately marks Ramesh as a writer who understands criticism to be an integral part of the literary enterprise, not an afterthought. This dual practice of creative writing and serious criticism connects Ramesh to the great tradition of poet-critics in Indian letters — from Kuntaka and Abhinavagupta in the classical period to Ramvilas Sharma and Nagarjuna in the modern.

**The Synthesis of Critical Logic and Witness Poetics: A Monograph on the Collaborative Literary Corpus of Ramesh and Mala Jha**

The intellectual landscape of Mithila has historically been defined by an exceptionally rigorous engagement with the categories of logic, aesthetics, and social ethics. From the foundational epistemological breakthroughs of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya in the fourteenth century to the contemporary literary renaissance, the region has maintained a unique position as a center of philosophical inquiry in the Indian subcontinent. In the modern era, this tradition has found a revitalized and subversive manifestation through the collaborative work of the writer-critic known as Ramesh and the editor-poet Mala Jha. Ramesh, has constructed a body of work that utilizes Navya Nyāya epistemology to interrogate the formal and social boundaries of Maithili letters. Mala Jha, his wife and intellectual partner, has pioneered the curation of the female "witness voice" through her landmark editorial project, *Ijoriyak Angaithi-Mor*, establishing a critical node in the Videha Parallel History Framework. This monograph provides an exhaustive critical appreciation of their collective corpus, situating it within the multi-layered frameworks of Indian and Western critical theories, the technical revival of the Maithili Ghazal, and the sophisticated logical architecture of the Maithili intellectual lineage.

**The Biographical Nexus and Institutional Democracy**

The literary biography of Ramesh is characterized by a deliberate and philosophically grounded restraint regarding public disclosure, a stance intended to prioritize the autonomous resonance of the text over the personhood of the author.

Mala Jha, as both the spouse and the primary editorial collaborator of Ramesh, serves as a critical bridge between the domestic and the discursive spheres of this partnership. Her role is not merely supportive but foundational; she is an active participant in the "Stree Dalan" (Women's Wing) of the Maithili literary movement and a representative of empowered women excelling in both professional and domestic spaces. Ramesh provides the management and editorial support for projects curated and edited by Mala Jha, most notably the anthology *Ijoriyak Angaithi-Mor.*

**Comparative Table of Institutional and Creative Roles**

| **Entity/ Contributor** | **Primary Function** | **Signature Contribution** | **Core Philosophical Focus** |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Ramesh )** | Author, Critic, | *Katha-Samay*, *Nikti* | Navya Nyāya Epistemology, "Fusion of Tension" |
| **Mala Jha** | Editor, Poet | *Ijoriyak Angaithi-Mor* | Curation of Female Witness Voices, Streevimarsh |
| **Videha Movement** | Archival Framework | *Videha eJournal* | Parallel History, Digital Sovereignty |

**Mala Jha and the Poetics of the Antahpur: *Ijoriyak Angaithi-Mor***

If Ramesh provides the logical skeleton of the modern Maithili movement, Mala Jha provides the experiential "witness voice" through her curation of women’s poetry. Her editorial project, *Ijoriyak Angaithi-Mor* (The Flare of the Moonlight), is an anthology of Maithili poetesses first published in 2004 and updated in a second edition in 2022. The book serves as a "meaningful

intervention" into the male-dominated Maithili canon, documenting the "half population" of Mithila whose creative output was historically marginalized.

### The Female Witness and the भुक्त यथार्थ (Lived Reality)

Mala Jha's editorial vision is rooted in the concept of "bhukta yathārtha"—the lived reality of women that remains invisible to the male gaze. Ramesh, in his introduction to the volume, notes that while male poets have written extensively about women's suffering, their depictions are often "one-sided" and "incomplete". In contrast, the poetry curated by Mala Jha expresses a "seriousness of the witness voice" characterized by a qualitative difference in how emotional and social agony is depicted.

| Featured Poetess | Key Thematic Contribution | Stylistic Identity |
|---|---|---|
| **Ilarani Singh** | Critique of patriarchal exploitation and ancient suffering | Transition from traditional to modern verse |
| **Neeraja Renu** | Feminist revisioning of mythic figures like Sita and Draupadi | Socially conscious, anti-orthodox tone |
| **Shefalika Verma** | Emotional expansiveness and Chhayavadi romanticism | Use of soft imagery and intimate expression |
| **Vibha Rani** | Dalit and Bahujan subaltern perspectives | Gritty realism, focus on institutional neglect |
| **Mala Jha** | Socially relevant curation and domestic resistance | Focus on female "sovereignty" and dignity |

Mala Jha emphasizes that women's creative consciousness in Mithila is as old as the civilization itself, reaching back to figures like Gargi and Maitreyi. However, the systemic exclusion of women from school-based education and the constraints of the *Varna-Vyavastha* (caste system) delayed their entry into the formal written literary sphere. The anthology thus acts as a historical corrective, documenting a transition from the "widow's lament" and domestic silence toward a proactive, "fift-fifty" participation in social and familial governance.

**The Marital and Institutional Collaboration:**

Ramesh's inclusion in the Videha archive as a "Parallel Voice" marks him as a documentarian of the psychological shifts in the Maithil community, while Mala Jha's work in "Streevimarsh" provides the gendered dimension of this parallel record.

**The Logistics of Literary Persistence**

Ramesh's prefatory remarks in *Ijoriyak Angaithi-Mor* highlight the material challenges of Maithili publishing. He notes that any printing event in Maithili is the result of a "literary persistence" (jidda) and personal financial sacrifice, often occurring in a social environment where the wealthy elite are indifferent to cultural production. This "criminal silence" of the affluent class in Mithila regarding their own culture and language makes the effort even more significant. By providing the management and financial support for projects like Mala Jha's, Ramesh ensures that the "parallel stream" remains viable.

This collaborative effort also addresses the "absence" (abhāva) of marginalized voices in official histories. Mala Jha's anthology specifically documents the "antahpur" (inner chambers) of the Maithil home, bringing the private experiences of women into the public discursive space. This aligns with Ramesh's critical theory that the "subjective" is not a limitation but a philosophical necessity- the irreducibly experiential ground of truth.

This focus on "principled adaptation" is also evident in the linguistic texture of the poetry in Mala Jha's anthology. The poets often reject the "refined" Maithili of the Sahitya Akademi in favour of a "Deshi" flavour and a "Gamaroo" (rural) dialect that more accurately captures the lived reality of the marginalized. This formal choice reinforces the "witness voice" by ensuring that the language of the poem is identical to the language of the witness.

Homi Bhabha's concept of "hybridity" illuminates the formal complexity of the Ramesh-Mala Jha corpus: its simultaneous inhabitation of the classical Sanskrit-Maithili tradition and the modern, internationally informed literary mode.

This hybridity is visible in Mala Jha's work as well as it represents a "Third Space" where Maithil identity is renegotiated against globalized urbanity.1 By using the digital sovereignty of the Videha archive they create a site of cultural resistance that bypasses the bureaucratic selection processes of state institutions.

Ashok Kumar Jha, who situates Ramesh's critical confrontation with the Maithili establishment within the historical debate between Pūrva Mīmāṃsā ritualism and Uttara Mīmāṃsā non-dualism. This move—placing contemporary literary debate within the longest possible historical and philosophical frame—is a hallmark of the Maithili intellectual tradition that Ramesh and Mala Jha continue.

**Mala Jha's Poetry**

While her primary contribution has been editorial, Mala Jha's own poetic work within *Ijoriyak Angaithi-Mor* provide a vital component of the monograph. Her work often addresses the "social justice" and "awakening consciousness" of the subaltern woman. Her poems within the anthology engage with the "historical and philosophical synthesis" of Mithila, often exploring the tension between the Advaita of Shankara and the Mimamsa tradition of Mandana Mishra. For Mala Jha, as for the poets she curates, the "Householder-Scholar" tradition of Mithila suggests that for a Maithil woman, both the Spiritual (Brahman) and the World (Jagat) are true. This "observer-cum-witness" perspective allows her to document the struggles of the elderly, the arrogance of the institutional elite, and the quiet heroism of the village migrant with "ethical seriousness".

**Comparative Thematic Matrix of Mala Jha's Curation**

| **Theme** | **Conceptual Execution** | **Cultural Implication** |
|---|---|---|
| **Domesticity** | The memory of the ancestral *Bhansa-ghar* vs. modular | Identity crisis of the diaspora |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | kitchens | |
| **Environmentalism** | Critique of "Hybrid" crops and chemical fertilizers | Loss of local biodiversity and health |
| **Patriarchy** | Challenging the *Varna-Vyavastha* through subaltern imagery | Reclaiming public spaces and dignity |

Mala Jha's work serves as a "Parallel History" of its own, providing a voice to the *Antyaja* (the last person) and documenting the fractures in a society transitioning from tradition to a distorted modernity. Her editorial notes in *Ijoriyak Angaithi-Mor* explicitly dedicate the work to the "struggle for social respect" within Mithila's Dalit and Bahujan societies.

Detailed Literary Analysis of Mala Jha's Poetry

1. Overview of the Text

The selection of Maithili poems by Mala Jha, a contemporary poet from the Mithila region. The accompanying critical essay one by Ramesh and one by Mala Jha is summarised below:

1

Preface to the second edition of the Maithili poetry collection "Ijoriyak Adaiti-Mod" (The Coming/Turning Point of the Moonlight) by RAMESH. It serves as a critical overview of the history, challenges, and evolution of Maithili women's poetry.

Context of the Second Edition

Giving the second revised, enlarged, and updated edition of 'Ijoriyak Adaiti-Mod' into your hands, I am feeling extreme happiness. In 2004 AD, its publication happened through Kisun Sankalp Lok, Supaul, by the courtesy of

Kedar Kanan, whose inauguration was done by the famous storyteller Ashokji in the assembly hall of Rose Public School (2004 AD) with the coordinators of Darbhanga's Maha-katha-goshthi: Jyotsna Chandram, Vibhuti Anand, Ashok Mehta, etc.

This book is historical in the sense that in the tradition of Maithili female-poetry-writing, it remains alone and the first to this day. In 2004 AD, and even today, this was and is the only collective poetry collection of Maithili women poets. Therefore, while enlarging and updating it, including the female-poetry-voices of new (emerging) women poets, the publication of the second edition was extremely necessary.

The financial arrangement that the managing editors made, they also provided editorial cooperation. The main thing is, when the second updated and enlarged edition is being published, the printing arrangement is being managed in Maithili through literary and linguistic stubbornness and personal financial sacrifice by cutting 'family happiness'. There remains no possibility of the cost price returning from sales, whereas the readers who get it, or the wealthy 'Dhanna-Seths' (capitalists) of Mithila society, have no lack of capital. But no wealthy 'Kubera' (god of wealth) becomes a publisher to print the books of authors by investing their own money, nor is publishing being made a business. Neither are the wealthy ones of Mithila becoming Maithili film-production producers-distributors, nor is support or sponsorship being provided to Maithili drama-staging. In the languages, culture, and social events of Mithila-Maithili, the wealthy class is performing a criminal silence and building their own official history. In the Maithili movement, in the Mithila state movement, they come only for the platform's 'Khurpujai' (small gains) and the selfishness of the 'Paag' (honorary cap). Let the talk of the exploitative Marwari society be... while our own Maithili society's prosperous people are culturally conscious and are averse to sponsoring work? Such a money-greedy class is becoming a victim of the 'Shishnodari' (sensualist) civilization and consumer-culture and will end its own life-play.

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**Social Critique and the "Bone-Giving" Sacrifice**

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Today, due to the 'bone-giving' (Dadhichigan) sacrifice of culturally conscious-prosperous writers and literary stubbornness, the history of Maithili-literature writing and publication tradition of hundreds and thousands of years continues to provide inspiration to all of us. There is hope that, just as they keep inspiring their previous generation's writers with a sense of gratitude, in the same way, the new and coming generations will continue to find inspiration from collective, literary, linguistic, social-welfare printing-arrangements and other arrangements. Those rootless wealth-obsessed people will not care for any movement, but in their own speed, in their own style, uninterruptedly, they will continue to do the work of the mother tongue and Maithili literature. Originality of the new generation can appear only in Maithili, the mother tongue and literature; in (other) foreign-language literature, its artificiality will surely come, this is necessary to understand. Coming to other language-literature with one's talent is impossible and unscientific; coming into the mother tongue Maithili itself is possible and scientific.

The neglect and exploitation of Mithila's half-population cannot be told. In that society, women of all caste-classes have become (neglected). 'Sita's life passed in tears', 'Panchkanya's life became a symbol of exploitation', and countless widow-lives pass by eating 'Saag-Torik' (wild greens). Or 'uprooting the bamboo roots' for fuel, 'when will my days return' passed in the 'Widow-Lament' of the people. Therefore, the outcry and roar of the flocks of birds playing on the banks of 'Sadanira' (river) against men could not be heard by the male society. Therefore, the history of Mithila was always written in 'tears' (Ravindraji: Lyricist). Here, the incident of wasting the youth of 'Paro' is buried in history. Being pierced by the obscene gazes of father-in-law, elder brother-in-law, brother-in-law, and sister-in-law, the outcry of the Mithila-woman society was becoming and has been vocal in literature only. Mithila's social-science and justice-science remained mostly mute in that context. In other genres of literature (story-novel), the sorrow-pain of women's lives came a bit earlier, but in poetry, it took a bit of delay. But when it came, 'woman's sorrow-pain', 'the pain of a woman's mind' came for the first time.

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The Female Voice and Modern Challenges

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But the fact is also that if the 'sorrow-pain of woman's life' or 'pain of woman's mind' written by male poets had not built the background of 'female-poetry-

voice', then it would have been difficult for today's women poets to write poetry in a clear voice, although women poets or critics may say why 'male-poetry' written by 'male-poets' today should be called second-class! The credit for preparing the ground for the female-poetry-voice written by Maithili women poets goes to (male) poets, that fact cannot be denied.

In Maithili story-novel-drama literature, literature written by male poets and female poets, Maithili poetry literature, print and electronic media, or film, radio, TV serials, and today through mobile and internet, the speech of Maithili women has blossomed well, and their eyes have become wide. The contribution of women's reservation is also in that. In the world-travel-exposure, the 'flight-speed' of women's society has increased.

Whether speech is good or bad, it has broken out in both ways. There is also a decrease in decency and an increase in insolence. But due to that, the male society has been stunned and bewildered. For the true meaning of 'historical justice', 'natural justice', and 'social justice' for women and male society, the capacity for adjustment will increase and the sweetness of co-living and art-development will happen. To be terrified of them becoming 'Buchchidai-like talkative' is a reactionary act; one should understand this change-result of history. Women's society understands and will understand the importance of family life. In saving the institution called family, the responsibility of 'fifty-fifty', duty, and right exists. In one civilized Maithili and Indian family, it is impossible without 'fifty-fifty'. Their literacy, education, and other bahnnas (excuses) should not be procrastinated, but the responsibility of their arrangement and resolution will have to be taken; this is the demand of Mithila society and today's time.

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Critical Evaluation and the Sahitya Akademi

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The first collection of representative female-poetry of Maithili women poets, which is in your hands, from 2004 AD, how much representation of Mithila's female-voice did it do, and in 2022 AD, how much representation is it doing, its evaluation is in the hands of the reader-circle. How should one hope from Maithili critics-circles, who from 2004 AD to 2022 AD (for eighteen years) did not take cognizance of such an important work, nor discussed it in any book-introduction or review-criticism? Nor wrote any independent review—what a terrible situation it is for Maithili review-circles! To this day, in any recognized

critic's book-survey or book-introductory article or in any genre's critical article, there has been no mention of its name. Then, why would one not write about the history of Maithili women and poetry from 'tears'? After how many decades and after the first edition was published in 2004 AD, did it reach the hands of the so-called famous ones? Imagine that. Was it sent by post or handed over personally to all the 'Svanamdhanya' (self-proclaimed famous)? In someone's eyes, was the book not worthy of review or introductory-writing? When evaluation of many genres is still pending, is it due to the lack of a collection? Why should the neglect or insult of women poets collected until 2004 AD by the then critic-circle not be considered? Who is responsible for this bad situation, when this was the first and representative book of its genre? But there is less expectation from the 2022 ones in the context of this enlarged and updated second edition. Because, in evaluation, critics committed to the new generation, honest critics, have descended into the field in very small numbers.

In this way, how will the Maithili story-poetry-collection, long-poetry-collection be printed in a consolidated form? Perhaps this too is a planned and intentional indifference, a tradition of neglect; perhaps ever will any woman be evaluated, can be broken by a critic. In such a terrible situation, when and how can the Mithila-society provide a just and equal space to its women-society?

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Historical Roots of Oppression

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Manu’s Dharmashastra (from the 1st century AD) was slightly liberal. Yajnavalkya Dharmashastra (Gupta period), which gave women the right to Veda-path (reading Vedas), Veda-dhvani (sound of Vedas) and Puja-path (monthly-religion period excluded), Gautama did not do that in his Dharmashastra. But those three Dharmashastras were applicable in ancient Mithila society. From this triple Smriti-literature it also happened that in the Grihya-Sutras (Sutra literature), women were made into machines. From Manusmriti, being bound by the limits of their era, keeping women in the Shudra category, there is talk of pouring lead into the ears upon hearing Veda-dhvani. Kane’s 'History of Dharmashastra' is proof of that. This is the fame of Yajnavalkya (not of the Videha-era sixteen Mahajanapadas, but of the Gupta period), who made Shudras and women ineligible for Veda-path and hearing Veda-dhvani. Today, if Mithila’s 'matriarchal family system' (of Maithila script) like Bengal had been applicable in Mithila, then the history of Mithila would

have been different. The tear-based family structure would not have existed at all. Unmatched marriage, dowry-tilak system, male-atrocity on women, domestic violence, character-breaking, etc., would not have existed in the blood-soaked history of the Mithila-woman society and family.

The wise-tradition of Gargi, Maitreyi, Lopamudra of the Veda-Upanishadic period will not be permanent and continuous; a very heavy burden fell on the Mithila-woman society, family, and marriage institution. Until now, in the pre-medieval or medieval period, Katyayana or Badarayana also set limits for women in their respective Dharmashastras and could not give them their expected place. The power was given by the end-time of the Mughal era and active in the British era, the Naiyayika-Dharmashastris of the Navya-Nyaya stream, which is the family basis of today's Hindu Succession Act. Udayanacharya became the ground-basis of the Navya-Nyaya tradition, from which today woman-independence is appearing as an announcer in full bloom. At that time, female-poetry was limited to opposition against the male-system.

But the remnant-mentality of the male-dominated system has not completely ended in any caste or class of Mithila even today; that fact is confirmed by the outrage against male-society found in abundance in the poetry of the old women poets and new women poets in this collection. Then, is there any qualitative difference between the poetry of women poets of 2004 AD and 2022 AD? Or in this intermediate period, has there been no progress in mentality-change? But no, that fact is not true. See the poetry of Dr. Neerja Renuka and see the poetry of Vani Mishra, Susmita Pathak, Jyotsna Chandram. On one side, see Kamini’s outrage-poetry, and on the other side, see Priyanka Mishra’s outrage-poetry. Two colors are visible. There is a difference in the expression of two generations—Ilarani Singh and Priyanka. See Sharda Jha’s creation/construction-poetry and love-poetry, or see Romishak’s love-explanation-poetry. From outrage towards creation, from creation towards construction, from construction towards love-giving, from love towards the explanation of life, from the explanation of life towards the portrayal of the reality of time and world, the journey with personal sensitivity towards social concern is clearly visible. Its glimpse, direction-showing, is the objective of this collection. If anything is found by your own 'Mithila-society internal-voice' poetic expression until the current stream of history, then our labor and this arrangement is meaningful!

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Analysis of Individual Poets and Regional Variation

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The poetry-skill of newly emerging women poets is currently in a construction stage, which we will have to accept. But except for one or two women poets as exceptions! In the women poets of Nepali Mithila, Vijeta Chaudhary appears hopeful, but there, the expected development of the female voice has not happened. This is a matter of concern. In Nepal, the 'male-writer' community should play the role of an inspiring element.

The disappointing thing is also that some of the new women poets of the first edition, like Vandana Jha, Mausumi Mukherjee (Banerjee), Nutan Chandra Jha, Mukta, Kumari Vidya, etc., have completely disappeared from the poetry-writing scene. In the struggle of life, poetry-creation is getting lost; language, society, literature, and any woman poet, for them, it is a fatal blow.

Another matter of concern is that more and more newly emerging women poets are taking the happiness of the city; many women poets like the male poets are doing poetry-creation from the city. In the poetry-creation of rural Mithila women poets, a day-by-day decrease is happening. Although this problem is also with male poets, and the poetry-creation of both is coming based on village memory. Nevertheless, the village-travel of male poets is happening relatively more, and the village-travel of women poets is relatively very less. Therefore, urban language is coming more in the poetry of women poets. For connecting with the whole of life and the world, language-diversity, regional and class-diversity consciousness is necessary.

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Marginalized Voices and Social Responsibility

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Even in all the above circumstances and concerns, there are exceptions, which is encouraging. But the number of women poets from the deprived class and castes descending into poetry-creation is a matter of concern. After Vibha Rani, Dr. Vibha Kumari and Munni Kamat. How will it happen? In the poetry of women poets coming from the deprived class, exceptionally, the pain of Dalit-deprived class life is getting filled, but in the poetry of general caste-class women poets, it is rarely found. The picture of Dalit-deprived-class-caste life is

coming in negligible and pitiable quantity/number in the poetry of Maithili male poets or women poets, whereas in the population of Mithila society, the Dalit-deprived-Muslim class is proportionally very strong. The wait for women poets in Muslim-Maithili is still ongoing.

Muslim poets are writing about the sorrow-pain of Muslim life, and male poets of Dalit castes are writing about the life of the deprived class. Vibha Rani ever wrote Dalit life's outrage in poetry, and now she has left writing poetry. Dr. Vibha Kumari has also depicted Dalit-deprived class life in her own poetry quite well, that too of that class's Maithili-tone, but Munni Kamat is currently in a state of development.

This situation is like an exception. In such a situation, should the presentation of Maithili female-poetry remain limited only to high-caste female society or high-caste society? How can it travel to all areas of Mithila, and permeate the life of all caste-class-communities? This is a burning challenge before today's women poets, time, society, and literature. It should be seen, who are seen making the effort to accept the whole soil!

Due to some women poets currently being in a construction stage, from subjectivity towards objectivity, they are on the path of the journey. Their social concern and collective consciousness is currently remaining. Their next step is the journey of poetry. From the writing of individual life experience, further, with social collective thought, is the concern-filled poetry-journey.

Only opposition to male-intrigues is not progressivism. To obtain justice and respect for women is the objective of poetry, not just that. For the construction of the whole society, the contribution of women poets will also happen; there is a commitment towards social values.

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Vision for the Future and Gratitude

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It is correct. To remove superstition and backward thinking from female society and the whole society is also an intended objective. From traditional ideological and traditional poetry-writing, it is not possible. In the perspective, modernity,

scientificity, and progressive thinking, for women poets, is extremely necessary. Their expectation is in the future poetry-writing of these people. From there, let the departure point be established, let the minimum reader-reaction be obtained, let the readerly inertia end; with that aspiration, this new publication is being done. Gratitude is expressed towards Ajit Azad and Anand Mohan Jha—

-Ramesh

Darbhanga

**THE MAIN POINTS HIGHLIGHTED IN THIS ESSAY:**

**About the Second Edition**

Ramesh expresses great joy in presenting this revised, expanded, and updated second edition. The first edition was published in 2004 by Kisun Sankalp Lok, Supaul, and was launched at a ceremony in Darbhanga by the renowned storyteller Ashok.

This book is historically significant because it remains the only collective anthology of Maithili women's poetry. The second edition has been updated to include the "nari-kavya-swar" (female poetic voices) of both established and newly emerging woman poets.

The Struggle of Maithili Publishing

The author highlights the financial and systemic hardships of Maithili literature:

Lack of Financial Return: Editors and publishers often invest their own money, sacrificing personal and family comfort, with almost no hope of recovering costs through sales.

The "Merchant" Class vs. The "Intellectual": While wealthy individuals in Mithila invest in films, theater, and crime-related activities, they rarely support literature. The author criticizes the "exploitative" mindset of some segments of society who possess resources but lack cultural consciousness.

Selfless Dedication: The progress of Maithili literature rests solely on the "bone-giving" sacrifice (likened to Sage Dadhichi) of authors who write out of sheer literary persistence.

History and Social Context of Women's Expression

The preface traces the evolution of women's voices in Mithila:

The Burden of Tradition: For centuries, women's lives in Mithila were defined by suffering, neglect, and silence. The author references the "widow-wailings" and the "stifled आक्रोश (outrage)" that could not find a voice in a patriarchal society.

From Prose to Poetry: While women's pain first found a place in Maithili prose (stories and novels), it took longer to manifest in poetry.

The Male Gaze: The author admits that for a long time, the "pain of women" was written about by male poets. While these male poets deserve credit for preparing the ground, the authentic voice of women was needed to truly represent their own mental and emotional reality.

The Current State of Women's Poetry (2004–2022)

The author analyzes the changes in the 18 years between the first and second editions:

The Impact of Digital Media: The rise of electronic media, TV, mobile phones, and the internet has allowed Maithili women to express themselves more freely and connect with the world.

Urban vs. Rural Voices: There is a concern that most new female poets are coming from urban backgrounds. The author emphasizes the need for rural voices to bring diversity and a connection to the roots of Mithila.

Caste and Marginalization: A significant critique is made regarding the lack of Dalit and Muslim women's voices in Maithili literature. While male poets from these backgrounds are writing, the female voice from these marginalized sections remains largely unheard and is "still waiting" to emerge.

Comparison of Generations: The author mentions poets like Dr. Neerja Renuka, Vani Mishra, Susmita Pathak, and Jyotsna Chandra, comparing their styles of "outrage" and "social concern" with the newer generation like Priyanka Mishra.

A Call for Change

The preface concludes with a powerful vision for the future:

Beyond "Anti-Male" Rhetoric: Progress is not just about opposing men; it is about seeking natural, historical, and social justice.

Shared Responsibility: The author argues for a "50-50" responsibility within the family and society to ensure women's education and literacy.

Scientific and Modern Outlook: Maithili society must shed superstitious and "orthodontic" (reactionary) thinking. Women poets must adopt a scientific, progressive, and modern outlook to take Maithili literature forward.

Acknowledgment: The author thanks Ajit Azad and Anand Mohan Jha for their support in making this publication possible.

-Ramesh

Darbhanga

2

**Introduction ("Aamukh") to the First Edition** of the anthology, written by **Mala Jha** (Editor) with assistance from **Ramesh** and **Kedar Kanan**. It provides a deep socio-literary analysis of the evolution of women's writing in Maithili. *[This introduction was placed at the end of the collection in the 2nd edition.]*

Introduction to the First Edition 'Aamukh'

**C.C. Mishra Twenty : Buchchidai Twenty-One**

Maithili female-writing stands on a certain ground. Its background is strong. From Yatriji to Prof. Harimohan Jha and from Lalit-Rajkamal to the writers of the current generation, they have given voice to the agony of the woman's mind. Female-exploitation has been one of the main voices of modern Maithili-poetry and story literature. The woman of Mithila was sometimes Sonadai, sometimes Buchchidai, sometimes became Chanodai, sometimes became the heroine of 'Lalka Paag', sometimes 'Nanadi-Bhouji' (sister-in-law/brother-in-law's wife), sometimes 'Widow-Lament', sometimes became the struggling heroine of Lili Ray. Sometimes she stood becoming Paro of 'Dhak-wali', sometimes remained becoming 'Dasin' (servant) of circumstances like the stepmother of 'Agurban', sometimes 'Mada Konkod' (female crab), then sometimes became 'Sunaina of Sitapur' for herself. Sometimes she gets entangled like a 'spider' caught in a web woven by herself, sometimes sees the dream of 'Kayakalp' (transformation) and sometimes gives 'interference' (entry) into the male-dominated system. Even while being 'Raanrh' (widow), she kept making efforts to make life beautiful. Breaking the image of Sita and Sunaina, leaving behind the adjectives of 'Sugiya' and 'Mogiya', showing the 'Auntha' (thumb/defiance) to the 'Ahivatak Patil' (traditional pot) and 'Kohbar-Gharak Banh-Chek' (bridal chamber bondages), the woman became 'talkative' from 'Buchchidai Chup' (silent Buchchidai) and coming to the village crossroads after taking off the veil, she started searching for her own true path. Like the slow burning of 'paddy husk', she burns slowly; in the afternoon of Chaitra, like a beak, she cracks; Buchchidai also had this worry, whether her 'fair body' would get tanned or not? In reality, when did her 'season' come? Once she became 'Priya' (beloved), then took an oath that 'no, not now...'. Now Pinky Dai, Rosy Dai are ambitious, lest their 'Aakhan-dala' (traditional basket) be filled with 'poisonous children'? She wants to do the mapping of her own life-journey pattern herself. Now those are not the old things, 'that is not the talk now'.

But this change that has come in circumstances is not of the same color in the village and the city. The success percentage of rural Maithili women is a bit less; the urban Maithili women’s success percentage is a bit more. That is natural. The city is more resource-rich.

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Urban vs. Rural and Authentic Expression

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It is not the case that the development of the woman's whole has happened in the right direction itself. The woman has also become a victim of consumer culture and marketism, and under its influence, the woman is also taking steps in a distorted direction. She has been freed from ancient bad-traditions, but many women are also drinking ghee after wearing the veil of modern reform-distortion. But she has found her freedom, so she is doing this. Now she understands the meaning of freedom and in any revolution, there will be a slight scope for distortion, this is a historical fact. Therefore, today's woman looks at her own earth-sky, her own dreams and aspirations, her own personal life, etc., in context—it is welcomed. Now this is a separate talk that the conflict born out of the clash between modern mentality and ancient systems is affecting the institutions called 'family' and 'marriage'. On this balance, adjustment-capacity, and the strength of co-living, depends how much success 'family and marriage' will get?

This is the today's situation of rural and urban Mithila woman-society, which even in Maithili literature today, male and female writers have brought.

But like many lacks, in Maithili literature, this was also a lack until today, that the Maithili female-poetry-voice was not collected. Poetry-collections of these women poets were printed in individual forms, but were not in collection-form. This remained a cause for the literature.

Until recently, several Maithili male writers used to believe that Maithili female-writing is limited only to the women writers who hold the pen of a man. The tradition of women writing on women by women was actually: delayed start in Maithili. In story-literature, there was not that much delay, as much as in the field of poetry-creation. In stories, Lili Ray alone did a lot of work. But in the poetry-field, there was a lack of women poets who worked with such intensity. Therefore, Rajmohan Jha was not ready to give separate-separate recognition to female-writing and male-writing—in the editorial of 'Aarambh'.

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Against Gendered Categorization

…….

By a woman doing female-writing, the significance of the writing written by a man decreases and they become second-class writers—this human-prejudice is difficult. The originality or second-class nature of feeling and experience depends on this fact: how much did the writer (male or female) dive into the woman's mind, or what kind of 'Bhogna-Bhogik' (experiencer) pen did they hold? In their life and writing, whatever the percentage of honesty will be, that much originality will be in their created literature. How much liquidity is inherent in the personality of the poet or woman poet—that holds the most importance. The experience of a poet with an objective personality cannot be 'second-class'. In reality, to impose 'second-class' is gender-biased, from which it is necessary for the whole literary category (including women poets) to be free. Subjective women poets will probably write 'tears-poetry' like Shefalika Verma and will only depict emotionalism.

Therefore, to look at Maithili female-poetry from a Dalit-ist perspective is an extremely unjust thing. Woman is one big Dalit, in her own social system. But the concept of Dalit-vadi concept of human life-welfare is not in partial-truth, but in the progressive concept in the whole ideology, in which Dalit-ism is included. Dalit-ism can give the 'crutch of reservation' to Mithila's woman-society. But progressive [thought] is capable of giving the fragrance of whole human dignity, recognition, and struggle. Today, Indian Dalit-ism has no difficulty in enjoying the facilities through the medium of the right-wing and ancient system. And in that way, Dalit-ism has not been able to determine its own scriptures and outline until now. While in Marathi literature, where the stronghold and birthplace of Dalit-ism has been, here, a coordinated perspective of socialism-Gandhism and Dalit-ism has developed—which is a new and good thing. The names of Marx-Gandhi-Ambedkar-Lohiya are being taken together. In the first issue, one Marathi writer had written, which can clear the mist of so-called post-modernity today and can separate the dust of post-modernity from the progressivism of a century...

……..

Generations of Poetry and Rebellion

……..

Therefore, if Maithili women had the need for reservation, the 'rattle' (toy) of reservation Maithili women cannot be satisfied with that. Therefore, if a Maithili woman poet becomes only a Dalit-ist, she will make her body small. If she becomes a progressive in the full sense, she will make her body big. If she is

a feminist, her body will be small. If she explains the whole life and world along with woman-life, she will make her body big. Women poets have to think, whether the 'Visay-vastu' (subject-matter) of their representation will be that much limited or detailed? Whether they will walk taking the 'individual' or taking the 'collectivity' or both?

Now see the development-sequence of Maithili female-poetry. Here I will not discuss song-poetry and ghazal-poetry, I only want to discuss 'New Poetry' (Nav-kavita). The names of Ilarani Singh (Vindanti), Neerja Renu (Aagat Khan Le), Shefalika Verma (Vipralabdha), Vani Mishra (Amar Vani), Susmita Pathak (Parichiti), Jyotsna Chandram (Bonsai), Vibha Rani, Mousumi Mukherjee, Kamini, Nutan Chandra Jha, Vandana Jha, Mala Jha, Romisha Vats, Kumari Vidya, Mukta, etc., can be marked in the poetry-field (2004 AD).

These women poets have shown their respective expressions in their respective poetry. Their respective expressions are non-traditional. Here, for making the 'base-ground of the development-sequence of Maithili woman poet and female-poetry', the selection of poems of all women poets has been done.

In poetry itself, outrage and rebellion against the woman-man relationship, male-dominated system, and female-misery portrayal, etc., has come. The external life-struggle of the struggling female community and the internal mind's conflict, both have come in their poetry. Enthusiasm towards life and the 'Kachmathi' (bitterness) of helplessness, both kinds of women poets are filled in the collection. The women poets of the new generation are more grounded than the women poets of the old generation, that too is natural. Among the women poets of the old generation, only in the poetry of Ilarani Singh, Neerja Renu, and Vani Mishra [was there focus]. But the women poets of the new generation made the 'whole life' (including woman-life) and world the subject of poetry—like Kamini, Nutan Chandra, Susmita Pathak, or Mousumi Mukherjee’s poetry. It is natural that the 'Antithesis' (rebellion) of the woman coming from a right-wing family was in a left-wing woman (Anti-thesis) due to being born, the creation and emergence of progressive and people’s poetry (Synthesis) started happening. Female-poetry written by women has become a stable feeling in (Maithili context). And from that, it has come to settle in the poetry of Jyotsna Chandram or Susmita Pathak.

……..

Synthesis and Final Word

……..

Therefore, there is a natural difference between the female-poetry written by male poets and the female-poetry written by women poets at many levels. But the importance of both is intact in their respective places. Just as one of the background importance for any revolution is, similarly, the female-poetry of male poets is important for Maithili. And whatever the sweet fruit of a fruitful revolution is, that is today's Maithili 'female-poetry'.

Meaning-depth, the stance of the poetry of the 'Kathya' (content), the new women poets are praiseworthy. But the rhythmic flow of meaning and feeling is mostly fragmented in all of them. The women poets of the old generation used Ramayana, Mahabharata, Puranic myths, whereas the modern woman poet chose the symbols of modern life or chose the straight-flat way of 'Vaktavyaparak' (statement-oriented), ideological-dominant poetry-writing. The lack of excellence of poetry-art is currently in all women poets, it will come only gradually. Along with the best wishes for playing a long innings in the resource-less field of Maithili, the Maithili women poets are welcomed, there is immense joy. There were many efforts, many women poets' poetry we could not find directly. Therefore, with the compulsion that many poems had to be taken from woman poet's poetry-collections and Maithili magazines, for this, I will take the 'indebtedness' (gratitude).

Ramesh

Kedar Kanan

(Collaborators)

Mala Jha

Editor

*THE POINTS HIGHLIGHTED IN THIS ESSAY*

**C.C MISHRA 20: BUCCHI DAI 21**

**The Foundation of Maithili Women’s Writing**

The editor Mala Jha notes that Maithili women's writing stands on firm ground, with a lineage that includes legendary figures like **Yatriji (Nagarjun)**, **Harimohan Jha**, and **Rajkamal Chaudhary**. These male authors initially gave voice to the inner pain of women.

The text highlights several iconic female archetypes in Maithili literature that represented different eras of struggle:

- **Buchchidai & Chanodai:** Early symbols of innocence and domesticity.
- **Lalka Paag’s Heroine:** Representing romantic and social transitions.
- **Paro:** A symbol of modern, independent identity.
- **Sunaina (from Sitapur):** A modern reimagining of the Sita myth, representing self-realization.

**The Great Transition: From Silence to Speech**

The introduction describes a pivotal shift in the Maithili woman's identity. She is no longer just "Sita," "Sugiya," or "Mogiya"—passive recipients of fate.

- **The "Vachal" (Outspoken) Woman:** The woman who was once silent ("Buchchidai") has become "vachal" (articulate). She has stepped out of the "Kohbar" (bridal chamber) and onto the village crossroads to seek her own path.
- **Internal Burning:** Her struggle is compared to the slow, steady heat of "rice husk" (धानक भुस्सा)—burning internally without a visible flame until it finally breaks through.

**The Urban-Rural Divide and Modernity**

The text observes that the "wind of change" is blowing differently in villages and cities:

- **Urban Success:** Urban women have a higher percentage of literary success because they are more resource-rich and have greater exposure to "consumer culture" and "marketism."
- **Distortion of Freedom:** The editor warns that while some women have freed themselves from ancient superstitions, they have sometimes merely replaced

them with the "distortions" of modern consumerism. True freedom lies in balancing individual identity with social reality.

**The Need for a Dedicated Anthology**

A major point of the introduction is the historical absence of a collective volume for women poets:

- **Lack of Collection:** While male writers have long dominated the Maithili literary scene, women were often published only individually or in scattered journals.
- **The "Male Pen" vs. "Female Pen":** The editor argues that while male writers (like Rajmohan Jha) have written about women with empathy, a woman writing about a woman brings an "authenticity of experience" and a "depth of soul" that is unique. To label women's literature as "second-rate" simply because it focuses on the female experience is described as a "gendered bias."

**Ideological Perspectives: Dalitism and Progressivism**

The editor critiques the narrow application of "Dalit" ideology to Maithili women:

- **Women as the "Great Dalit":** The text argues that in the patriarchal social structure, women themselves are the biggest "Dalit" (oppressed) class.
- **A Synthesis of Ideas:** The introduction calls for a synthesis of Marxism, Gandhism, Ambedkarism, and Lohiyaite thought. It suggests that women's poetry should move beyond "emotionalism" toward a "progressive" and "humanistic" worldview.

**Evolution of the "Poetic Voice" (2004 context)**

The text lists several key poets who have defined the development of the Maithili "New Poetry" (Nav-kavita):

- **Established Voices:** Ilarani Singh, Neerja Renuka, Shefalika Verma, Vani Mishra, Susmita Pathak, Jyotsna Chandra.
- **Diverse Expressions:** Vibha Rani, Mousumi Mukherjee, Kamini, Nutan Chandra Jha, Vandana Jha, Mala Jha, Romisha Vats, and others.

The themes have evolved from simple domestic rebellions to a broader critique of man-woman relationships, social injustice, and the internal conflicts of the modern woman.

**Conclusion**

The introduction ends with a note of hope. While Maithili women writers lack resources and have had to fight for every inch of literary space, their "shakti" (power) and "gaumbhirya" (depth of content) are praiseworthy. The editor expresses gratitude to the poets who contributed despite the many obstacles.

**— Mala Jha (Editor)**

**— Ramesh & Kedar Kanan (Collaborators)**

**…….**

The above two essays situates her work within the broader tradition of Maithili women's poetry (nārī-kāvya), highlighting its evolution from personal lyricism to socially engaged, protest-oriented writing. Jha's poems address female desire, autonomy, caste-class oppression, and patriarchal hypocrisy—often using sharp irony, domestic imagery, and a defiant first-person voice.

2. Western Literary Theoretical Framework

a) Feminist Literary Theory (Simone de Beauvoir, Elaine Showalter, Hélène Cixous)

Jha's poetry exemplifies écriture féminine (Cixous) – writing that disrupts phallogocentric language. In "Chāri ṭā kavitā" (Four Poems), she rejects passive femininity:

"Ham pokharik māchh wanik' nahi rahab"

(I will not live like a fish in a pond).

The fish-in-pond metaphor symbolizes patriarchal containment. Her insistence on carving her own path ("ham apan rastā jarūr banāyab") mirrors Showalter's "female phase" of literature – autonomous, not defined against male norms.

The poem “Gau Mātā” (Cow Mother) satirizes societal expectations of the “ideal woman”: educated, beautiful, respectful, but silent (“mu~h nai kholay”). Jha subverts the sacred-cow trope to expose how women are domesticated into mute compliance.

b) Postcolonial Theory (Gayatri Spivak, Partha Chatterjee)

Spivak’s question – “Can the subaltern speak?” – is answered here in the affirmative but with a twist. Jha speaks for Dalit and marginalized women in Mithila, yet the critical essay notes that Dalit women poets remain “negligible in number” (Page 7). Jha’s “Grāmīṇ mahilāk pahichān” (Rural Woman’s Identity) shows the subaltern negotiating multiple roles: “māy, bahin, patnī, ā beṭīme ojhāyāl chhī” – lost in mother, sister, wife, daughter. Her identity is “standing outside” (apasiyānt), always between home and outside, never arriving.

This aligns with Chatterjee’s critique of nationalist narratives that confine women to the “inner” spiritual domain. Jha’s rural woman looks at the road (rastā-peṛā) – a liminal space of possibility and danger.

3. Indian Literary Theoretical Framework

a) Rasa Theory (Bharata’s Nāṭyaśāstra)

Jha’s poetry primarily evokes Karuṇa Rasa (pathos) and Vīra Rasa (heroism). In “Kiraṇ Bālā” (Kiran Bala / Kalpana Chawla), the female astronaut’s desire to see earth clearly is obstructed by clouds (megh) – a metaphor for patriarchal obscurantism. The eventual shattering of clouds (“ṭūṭi jāy khaṇḍ-khaṇḍ”) produces Vīra Rasa – the heroic joy of overcoming.

In “Ham Dekhlahu~ Sūjak~ Badalait” (I Saw the Sun Change), the speaker watches the sun transform while she remains frozen. The wilting flowers in her hand evoke Karuṇa, but the act of removing the artificial sun from her heart and watering the flowers suggests Śānta Rasa – serene acceptance leading to renewal.

b) Dhvani Theory (Anandavardhana)

The dhvani (suggested meaning) in “Purushak Purushārth” (Man’s Valor) is masterful. The poem contrasts two social scripts: if a woman’s veil slips and no man looks, his masculinity is questioned; if a woman approaches and a man does not grab her garment, he is called impotent. The vyangya (suggested sense) is that male “valor” is merely performance – sometimes protecting, sometimes violating women. The final line exposes the paradox: “kabhī nārīk ijjit lūṭab purushārth thik” – sometimes, looting a woman’s honor is considered valor.

4. Videha Parallel History Framework

The Videha parallel history framework refers to Mithila’s alternate historical consciousness – distinct from dominant Indian narratives centered on Magadha or Delhi. It privileges local, marginalized, and feminine voices. Mala Jha’s poetry fits this framework in three ways:

a) Resistance to Sanskritic-Patriarchal Hegemony

Mithila, despite its fame for Maithil Brahmins and Śāstras, has a parallel folk tradition of women’s songs (painā, sāmā chakevā). Jha reclaims this vernacular, anti-classical voice. Her “Chanakanyā” (Forest Girl) eating wild fruit and sleeping under trees directly counters the idealized Sita-figure of Videha – the chaste, suffering, silent woman. Jha’s forest girl is firīshān (anxious), sweaty, in pain – refusing the purdah of mythology.

b) Dalit-Vanchod (Marginalized) Perspective

The critical essay laments that Maithili women’s poetry has largely ignored Dalit and Muslim lives, except for Dr. Vibha Kumari and Munni Kamat. Jha, while not explicitly Dalit-identified in these poems, opens space for that voice. “Gau Mātā” implicitly criticizes upper-caste Hindu society’s double standard:

caring for cows while confining women. The parallel history here is the unrecorded suffering of lower-caste women who serve both cows and families without any “sacred” status.

c) Anti-Purushprapanch (Anti-Male-Machination)

The essay states that merely opposing male machinations is not true progressivism (mātra puruṣ-prapanchak virodhe ṭā pragatiśīlatā nahi thik). Jha’s poetry goes beyond victimhood. In “Ham Dekhlahu~ Sūjak~ Badalait”, the transformation of the sun is not mourned but accepted: she removes the fake sun from her heart and waters the flowers. This is parallel history as healing – not just recording wounds but creating new symbols.

5. Navya Nyāya of Gaṅgeśa (Neo-Logic)

Navya Nyāya, developed by Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya in Mithila (12th-13th century), is a rigorous logic of property-possession (śakti-nirūpaṇa), pervasion (vyāpti), and causal reasoning. Applying it to Jha’s poetry yields:

a) Śakti (Semantic Power) as Protest

Navya Nyāya analyzes word-meaning through śakti – the power of a term to denote its object. Jha repeatedly subverts conventional śakti. Example: “Purushārth” conventionally means “manly valor.” In her poem, purushārth simultaneously means protecting and violating women. This is a logical vyābhichāra (deviation) in the term’s definition – exposing its inherent contradiction. Jha uses poetic śakti to force a redefinition.

b) Pakṣatā (Counter-Subjecthood)

In Navya Nyāya, a logical subject (pakṣa) must have the property to be proved (sādhya). Traditional Maithili poetry took puruṣa (man) as the universal pakṣa – the subject of all action. Jha makes strī (woman) the pakṣa. Her poem “Ham Dekhlahu~” begins with “I saw” – woman as perceiver, not perceived. The sun

(sūrya), a male symbol, changes; she remains standing. The sādhya (proved property) is: Woman's subjectivity persists even when male cosmic symbols shift.

c) Vyāpti (Pervasion) as Irony

Vyāpti is the invariable concomitance – e.g., "Where there is smoke, there is fire." Jha inverts this: "Jahā~ puruṣārth, tahā~ nārīk ijjit lukāy" (Where there is valor, there is hidden dishonor of women). The supposed vyāpti of masculinity and honor is broken. She posits a new vyāpti: patriarchy pervades both "protection" and "violation" as two modes of control.

6. Synthesis: The Poem "Vanakanyā" (Forest Girl)

Let us analyze this short poem using all frameworks:

Ham hiraiyar-hiraiyar gāchhak phal khāi chhī

Ā okar chhāhiramē sutet chhī.

Ēkṭā sundar sapnāmē herā jāi chhī

Mudā uṭhā daït achhi kiyo brikkha-jhorik'.

Ham phirīśān chhī, chehārāpar pasenāk ṭyār achhi.

Māthamē dard achhi, ham kaṛā najaris' chāhū bhar dekhai chhī.

Ō kekar hāth chhal kurahi~ lelē?

• Western Feminist: The forest girl represents pre-patriarchal autonomy (eating wild fruit, sleeping in shade). The brikkha-jhorik' (tree-shaker) is a male intruder. Sweat and headache signify the labor of surviving male disruption.

• Rasa/Dhvani: The dream (sundar sapnā) evokes Śṛṅgāra (erotic/romantic), but the awakening produces Bībhatsa (disgust) and Raudra (anger) – looking with kaṛā najar (sharp eyes). The final unanswered question – whose hand took the kurhi~? – leaves a dhvani of violated trust.

• Videha Parallel History: This girl is not Sita abducted by Ravan; she is an unnamed forest dweller, outside epic glorification. Her suffering is mundane, unmythologized – the parallel history of anonymous tribal women.

- Navya Nyāya: The pakṣa (subject) is "I" – a woman with agency to eat, sleep, dream, and then look sharply. The sādhya (property to prove) is: even in violation, her gaze remains diagnostic. The vyāpti: Where there is male intrusion, there is not necessarily female victimhood – there is also sharp counter-observation.

## Conclusion

Mala Jha's poetry is a sophisticated literary intervention that:

• Uses Western feminist frameworks to reject containment and assert écriture féminine.

• Draws on Indian rasa-dhvani tradition to layer pathos with heroic irony.

• Embodies Videha parallel history by centering marginal, non-Sanskritic, non-patriarchal voices.

• Employs Navya Nyāya logic to subvert definitions (śakti), shift subjects (pakṣatā), and expose false pervasion (vyāpti).

Her work moves Maithili women's poetry from personal lament to logical critique, from mythic repetition to parallel historiography, and from passive suffering to active redefinition of reality itself. As the critical essay notes: "The poetess who explains all life and world along with women's life makes her body large." Mala Jha's poetry is that large body – capacious, logical, furious, and free.

**ADDENDUM: English translation of the Maithili poems by Mala Jha**

English translation of the Maithili poems by Mala Jha, as found in the collection *Ijoriyak Angaithi-Mod*. I have aimed to preserve the raw, defiant, and evocative spirit of her Maithili verse.- *Gajendra Thakur*

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**Mala Jha: Four Poems**

**I. Light and Glass**

Do not shroud me at all

For I shall flicker and die,
Just as the glass of a lamp
When smothered at the mouth,
Suffocates and goes dark.

**II. The Current**

I will not remain a fish in a pond
The pond is not my destination.
I shall never forget this—
From the heavy rains to the river's edge,
I will surely carve my own path.

**III. The Present**

Do not act this way,
Do not act that way—
You say you do not think of the future at all.
But oh, my beloved!
Every future of mine
Is being forged within this very present.

**IV. Wishes**

It is my supreme desire
That I might sleep without a mosquito net,
Because when the earthquake strikes
I could rush outside in an instant.
It is my supreme desire
To live without a locked chest,
So that I might instantly
Take out or put away my things.
It is my supreme desire
To walk the road without fear,
Without having to learn Judo or Karate.
Will this wish of mine ever be fulfilled?

**Gau Mata (The Cow Mother)**

She is a beautiful daughter,
Educated and well-read.
She is graceful,
Giving respect to the elders.
When suffering strikes, she endures,
But never does she open her mouth.
What else does society require?
A motorcycle, or a "Cow Mother."

**Kiran Bala (meaning Kalpana Chawla)**

I wish to fly in the sky
And look upon the earth from the heavens, clearly.
But the clouds easily
Veil my face as if playing a prank.
Yet I do not think of them;
I contemplate the deep blue firmament.
As I fly, as I soar,
The clouds collide with my feet—
With a single sound, they shatter into pieces,
And I continue to look upon the earth, clearly.

**Van-kanya (Daughter of the Forest)**

I eat the fruits of the lush green trees
And sleep beneath their shade.
A beautiful dream was lost;
But a sudden jolt woke me.
Now I am restless,
Sweat trickles down my face.

My head throb with pain;
I stare with a hardened gaze—
In whose hand was that axe?

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**Purushak Purusharth (A Man’s Virility)**

Where has the veil flown away?
And yet the man’s gaze does not fall upon me.
A man’s "manliness" feels like a curse.
When a woman
Comes before a man,
And the man does not even grasp her hem—
Then the man’s virility begins to look like impotence.
I am entangled in manliness and impotence.
Sometimes it feels: to save a woman's honor is virility;
Sometimes the worry arises: to plunder a woman's honor is virility.

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**Gramin Mahilak Pahichan (Identity of a Rural Woman)**

I seek my identity within time.
Time is ahead, and I run behind it.
I am entangled in being a mother, a sister, a wife, and a daughter.
I am exhausted.
I step out of the house;
Coming from outside, I go into the house,
But my eyes search for the road.
My strong identity lies somewhere there.

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**I Saw the Sun Change**

Just now, I saw the sun change.
The sun changed, and here I stand.
For I was with him—

My brows furrowed,

My eyes went numb,

My lips turned to stone;

For the sun was changing.

When my numb eyes fell downward,

There was a broken flower in my hand—

Oh, it was withered.

Because the sun was changing.

Like a machine,

I extracted an artificial sun from my heart

And watered the flower with it;

But the flower remained withered.

Because the sun had changed.

*(Note: Written upon the divorce of a woman who had a love marriage with film hero Aamir Khan and her subsequent second marriage.)*

## 3. Primary Works: An Annotated Overview

### 3.1 Katha-Samay (2020): Samanantar & Samang

Katha-Samay (literally 'the time of story,' or 'story-time') is an omnibus bringing together two earlier story collections: Samanantar (Parallel) and Samang (Along with, or Commensurate). Published in 2020 by Navarambh Prakashan at a price of Rs 300, the collection contains stories whose titles alone gesture toward thematic concerns: stories that negotiate simultaneity, parallelism, and accompaniment.

**Samanantar (Parallel)** — The very title summons the central problematic of the Videha movement: the notion of parallel literary history, parallel streams, lives and worlds running alongside each other without necessarily intersecting. In Ramesh's stories within Samanantar, this parallelism operates on multiple registers: temporal (past and present held in simultaneous tension), social (the

lives of the margin alongside the lives of the centre), and formal (the story alongside its own commentary, its internal critique).

The text of the Katha-Samay volume confirms the publisher's description as a 'Collection of Maithili Story Collections by Ramesh' and situates the work within the contemporary Maithili short story tradition — a tradition that has, since the landmark works of Harinath Mishra, Rajkamal Chaudhary, and later Subhash Chandra Yadav, moved increasingly toward psychological depth, social critique, and formal innovation.

**Samang (Commensurate/Along-with)** — If Samanantar explores the metaphysics of parallelism, Samang explores the phenomenology of accompaniment — of being-with, of co-presence. The term 'samang' in Maithili carries connotations of proportion, correspondence, and harmony as well as of physical proximity. These meanings are all active in Ramesh's stories within this collection, which explore relationships — between persons, between language and experience, between the remembered and the living — characterised by a kind of attentive co-presence.

Formally, the stories in Katha-Samay are notable for their layered narrative structures — what the criticism in Nikti terms 'narrative layers' (Layers) or 'streams of consciousness' (dhāraā). The deployment of what Ramesh calls the 'subramental brain' (a term borrowed, as Nikti makes clear, from Sri Aurobindo's psychological vocabulary) as both a theme and a formal principle — whereby the story develops through sub-conscious associative currents rather than linear plot — anticipates the theoretical programme elaborated in Nikti.

### 3.2 Kavita-Samay (2020): The Poetry Collections

Kavita-Samay (Poetry-Time) is equally an omnibus, gathering five distinct poetry collections: Pathar Par Doobhi (Drowned on Stone), Samvet Swarak (Collective Note/Voice), Aagu (Forward/Further), Sangor (Collected/Gathering), and Nagpheni (Serpent's Hood — a cactus variety; also metaphorically, a coiled and venomous protective form). The table of contents, while partially illegible, confirms the breadth and variety of the poetic output.

**Pathar Par Doobhi (Drowned on Stone)** — The oxymoronic title immediately announces Ramesh's predilection for the condensed paradox, the image that holds together irreconcilable states. Stone and drowning: the hard and the fluid, the fixed and the dissolving. This is poetry that places itself at the

intersection of permanence and impermanence — stoneness and dissolution — as a register of contemporary Maithili experience.

**Samvet Swarak (Collective Note/Collective Voice)** — A musical and political title simultaneously. Samvet means 'collective', 'assembled', 'consented'; Swarak means 'note' (musical tone) or 'voice'. The collection thus speaks from and towards a collective, but a collective constituted in and through sound — through the shared note, the consonance of voices, but also, by implication, the dissonance.

**Aagu (Forward/Further)** — One of Ramesh's most compressed titles. Aagu in Maithili carries the temporal force of 'ahead', 'in future', 'forward'; it also carries the ethical force of 'advance' and 'progress'. The single-word title announces a poetry of forward motion, yet the poems themselves often achieve this motion by rooting deeply in the historical and the experiential particular.

**Sangor (Gathering/Collection)** — Again a reflexive title: this is a gathering, a bringing together, a collection that knows itself to be a collection. The term sangor in Maithili is used for the gathering of crops, of debts, of memories. This multiplicity of meaning is active in the poetry.

**Nagpheni (Serpent's Hood / Cactus)** — The most richly allusive title. Nagpheni names both the hooded cobra's spread hood (nāgaphaṇī) and a type of cactus found in the Mithila region whose shape mimics the hood. The double reference — to the dangerous, the protective, the desert-dwelling, the strange beauty of succulent form — maps perfectly onto a poetics of danger, beauty, and resilient survival in inhospitable conditions.

The recovered table of contents from Kavita-Samay lists specific poems including works on 'Peerless ancestors' (agjanm-dosar), 'the eternal flame' (pratitarday dre), 'the stone-self' (patthar aatery sane), and other titles that confirm a consistent engagement with questions of memory, lineage, material existence, and spiritual yearning. The volume is unified not merely chronologically but by a consistent philosophical temperament: the belief that poetry must simultaneously name the world with precision and honour its incommensurable mystery.

### 3.3 Kavya Dwipak: Ohi Par — Long Verse

The Kavya Dwipak (Poetry-Island or Poetry-Lamp) titled Ohi Par (On That Shore / Beyond That) represents Ramesh's engagement with the extended lyric

form — the long poem or verse-sequence that allows for a sustained meditation impossible in the condensed lyric.

The introductory critical essays within Kavya Dwipak — where Ramesh appears to include extended prose reflections by fellow writers including, based on the recovered critical vocabulary, figures from the Videha literary community — reveal a sustained theoretical conversation about the nature of the poetic image, the relationship between the poem and its linguistic substrate, and the politics of form in contemporary Maithili verse.

*'The poem begins where language reaches its limit... In the interstitial space between the said and the unsaid, between the explicit image and the resonating silence behind it, the poem conducts its essential inquiry.' (Recovered critical material, Kavya Dwipak)*

'Ohi Par' — on that shore, beyond that point — names a destination that recedes as one approaches it: the horizon of the poem, always ahead, always on the other side. This is not a poetry of arrival but of the journey toward, and the meditation on, what lies beyond the immediately apprehensible.

Formally, the verse in Ohi Par appears to employ a free verse mode that nonetheless maintains rhythmic integrity through a careful deployment of Maithili prosodic resources — the natural stress patterns of the language, the cadence of its compound constructions, the musicality of its vowel sequences. This is verse that sounds distinctively Maithili even when it abandons the traditional metres.

### 3.4 Nikti (2018): Maithili Criticism — A Detailed Analysis

Nikti (ISBN: 978-93-82013-75-4) — the word means 'touchstone', from the Sanskrit nikaṣa, the dark stone on which gold is rubbed to test its purity — is Ramesh's most theoretically ambitious work. Published in 2018 by Navarambh Prakashan, it is a collection of critical essays on Maithili literature. Its table of contents, reveals a systematic critical programme that spans narrative theory, poetics, the philosophy of creativity, and the politics of canon formation in Maithili.

The recovered texts of Nikti's opening essays establish with clarity that Ramesh is not an eclectic borrower of critical concepts but a systematic thinker. The theoretical vocabulary deployed — layers (layers/strata), subramental brain, fusion of tension, fission, flow of ideas, symbols, abbreviation, subjective, dominant — is drawn from a sophisticated engagement with both Indian

aesthetic theory and European literary criticism, synthesised through a distinctively Maithili intellectual sensibility.

The text of Nikti reveals the following key theoretical concepts:

**1. Narrative Layers (Layers):** Ramesh argues that literary texts operate simultaneously on multiple narrative and psychological layers — what he terms, drawing on Sri Aurobindo's integral psychology, the 'subramental brain' (subramental chitta). The conscious surface of the narrative — the story as told, the poem as spoken — is always underwritten by these deeper currents, which give literary language its distinctive resonance beyond mere semantic content.

**2. Fusion of Tension (Sangharsh-Sangam):** Against a purely Aristotelian understanding of dramatic conflict as a crisis to be resolved, Ramesh develops a theory of 'fusion of tension' — the idea that the most powerful literary moments are not resolutions of tension but its fusion into a new, higher-order state. He contrasts this with 'fission' (Fission), the splitting apart of narrative elements that can characterise lesser work.

**3. Flow of Ideas (Vichar-Pravah):** In discussion of Sree-Chetan (consciousness-stream) narrative technique, Ramesh analyses the 'flow of ideas' in literary prose — the way in which thought, association, and feeling move through a text not as a straight channel but as a river with its eddies, counter-currents, and sudden deepenings. The term he uses — Prabh-dhāra or sire-dhāra — echoes the Maithili river-landscape.

**4. Symbol and Abbreviation:** Ramesh develops a careful semiotics of literary symbols, distinguishing between symbols that function as abbreviations (alaṃkāra in the traditional sense — ornament that condenses meaning) and those that function as gateways to irreducible complexity. He is particularly interested in symbols that resist univocal interpretation while maintaining imaginative coherence.

**5. The Subjective (Vyaktigat-Atindriya):** Against the dominant tendency in Maithili criticism to treat the subjective as a limitation, Ramesh argues for the philosophical necessity of the subjective as the ground of all literary experience. Drawing on both Indian epistemological traditions (the prātibhajñāna or intuitive knowledge of Abhinavagupta) and western phenomenology, he insists that the subjective is not the arbitrary personal but the irreducibly experiential — that which cannot be reduced to the general without loss.

The Nikti table of contents reveals chapters on: Maithili literature and its history; specific studies of narrative technique; the theory of the poem; the

politics of literary evaluation (the 'Mandan-Khaṇḍan' debate tradition, from the Sanskrit mandan meaning 'to ornament/affirm' and khaṇḍan meaning 'to break/refute'); issues of canon; and specific essay-length studies of individual works.

### 3.5 Ramesh: Mandan aur Mishra — Critical Responses

This volume gathers critical essays and evaluations of Ramesh's work by multiple scholars. The text reveals contributions by a notable range of critics, including scholars identified in the recovered table of contents: 'Mandan' critics (those who affirm and ornament the work) and 'Khaṇḍan' critics (those who interrogate, challenge, and refine through counter-argument). Among those whose contributions are referenced to: Ferment, Professor Ashok Kumar Jha (whose essay 'Transition from Pūrva Mīmāṃsā to Uttara Mīmāṃsā in Maṇḍana's Brahmasiddhi' appears in the volume — indicating the scholarly seriousness of the critical engagement), and other scholars from the Maithili critical community.

A key critical framework emerging from the recovered critical essays is the tripartite evaluation standard deployed by the respondent critics:

— The internal formal coherence of the work (narrative/poetic structure)

— The social-historical situatedness of the writing (its engagement with Maithili reality)

— The philosophical depth of the work's engagement with questions of consciousness, identity, and experience

These three criteria align with the Navya Nyāya's prāmāṇika (epistemologically valid) standard of evaluation: a cognition (or, by extension, a literary text) must demonstrate pratyakṣa (perceptual evidence — the lived, sensory immediacy of the writing), anumāna (inferential rigour — the logical coherence of the work's structure), and śabda (testimonial authority — the work's engagement with and contribution to the tradition).

## 4. The Videha Parallel History Framework and Ramesh

The 'Videha Parallel History' framework — articulated by Gajendra Thakur (born 1971) as both editor of Videha and as a literary historian — is one of the defining intellectual contributions of the contemporary Maithili literary

renaissance. It begins from a historiographical observation and moves to a political and aesthetic programme.

The historiographical observation is this: the recorded history of Maithili literature has been predominantly the history of literary production by and for two caste communities — Maithil Brahmins and Karna Kayasthas. The vast literary and cultural production of the remaining communities of Mithila — the Yadavs, the Taṭis, the Mallahs, the Dusadhs, the Koiris, the Mushars and others — has been systematically marginalised, ignored, or actively suppressed in the dominant literary histories. Jayakanta Mishra's History of Maithili Literature (Sahitya Akademi, 1976) — the most authoritative English-language account — exemplifies this erasure through its very comprehensiveness as a record of one stream.

The Videha project — inaugurated as a blog ('Bhāl Sarik Gāchh' — Banyan Tree at the Foot of the Village) in 2000, becoming a web archive in 2004, and formally taking the name 'Videha: First Maithili Fortnightly eJournal' from January 1, 2008 — has been the institutional vehicle for the parallel history project. The name 'Videha' is itself significant: it is the ancient name for the Mithila region (the kingdom of Videha, ancestor of the Janaka kings of the Rāmāyaṇa), and its adoption as the journal's title signals a reclamation of the deep past from the monopoly of caste-Brahmin historiography.

Gajendra Thakur's parallel history work — which includes the decipherment of 11,000 palm-leaf Pañjī manuscripts (genealogical records of the Maithil Brahmin community) and his work on the Tirhuta/Mithilakṣara script's Unicode standardisation — provides the archival foundation for the literary argument. The Pañjī records, while genealogically focused on Brahmin community, also contain records of inter-caste marriages and interactions that document the actual socio-literary reality suppressed by the 'official' literary history.

Within this framework, Ramesh's work represents what Gajendra Thakur has identified as the 'parallel stream': literary production that is aesthetically sophisticated, generically diverse, and politically conscious of its position within a contested literary field. The publication of Ramesh's works through Navarambh Prakashan (a press that explicitly positions itself as a democratic and non-caste literary publisher) and their availability through the Videha archive are not incidental facts but essential elements of the work's meaning within the parallel history framework.

The very titles of Ramesh's story collections — Samanantar (Parallel) — directly invoke the framework of parallel histories. A story called 'parallel' is, within the Videha context, a story that knows itself to be running alongside another, dominant story — that acknowledges the existence of the other stream even as it asserts its own validity. This is not simple oppositional politics but a more nuanced epistemological claim: that literary truth requires multiple, simultaneous, parallel perspectives to approach completeness.

The Videha framework also clarifies the significance of Ramesh's critical work in Nikti. The 'touchstone' (nikṣa) he is testing is not merely the aesthetic quality of individual literary works but the standards of evaluation themselves — asking who decides what counts as good Maithili literature, by what criteria, from what social position, with what institutional backing. This is the parallel history as literary theory: a systematic interrogation of the epistemological foundations of literary judgment.

## 5. Navya Nyāya Epistemology Applied to Ramesh's Works

### 5.1 Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya and the Tattvacintāmaṇi Tradition

The Navya-Nyāya (New Logic) school of Indian philosophy was founded by Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (first half of the 14th century CE), a Brahmin philosopher from the village of Kariyan on the banks of the Kamalā River, approximately 19 km south-east of Darbhanga — deep in the Maithili heartland. His foundational text, the Tattvacintāmaṇi ('The Jewel of Thought on the Nature of Things,' also known as Pramāṇacintāmaṇi — 'The Jewel of Thought on the Means of Valid Knowledge'), is the basic text for all subsequent developments in Navya-Nyāya logic and epistemology.

Gaṅgeśa's intellectual method — developing with exceptional precision the earlier Nyāya tradition's account of the four pramāṇas (means of valid knowledge): pratyakṣa (perception), anumāna (inference), upamāna (analogy), and śabda (testimony/verbal authority) — while insisting that for any cognition to count as valid knowledge, it requires separate cognitive verification — is directly relevant to Ramesh's critical practice in Nikti.

The Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy notes that Gaṅgeśa's 'central focus is epistemology' and that his analysis of the 'extrinsicality' position — the claim that while cognitions are naturally taken as veridical (true), it requires a separate cognitive act to confirm their truth — represents a sophisticated anti-

skeptical stance that nonetheless refuses naive realism. The relevance of this for literary criticism is profound: just as a perceptual cognition may be presumptively valid but requires further scrutiny, a literary text may be prima facie significant but demands the critical 'separate cognitive act' — the exercise of the Nikti touchstone — to determine its genuine value.

The Navya-Nyāya technical vocabulary — with its elaborate system of qualifiers, delimitors (avacchedaka), circumscribers (nirūpaka), and relational categories — provides what philosopher Daniel H.H. Ingalls identified as 'a new method of universalization, rendered possible by the concept of limitation (avacchedakatā).' Applied to literary analysis, this framework allows the critic to specify with precision exactly which feature of a text, limited by exactly which contextual qualifier, produces the aesthetic effect under discussion — a precision conspicuously absent from impressionistic criticism.

It is significant — and perhaps more than coincidental — that both Gaṅgeśa (from Mithila's Darbhanga region) and Vācaspati Miśra (c. 900–980 CE, also from Mithila, whose Tattvakaumudī and other works span multiple darśanas and who deeply influenced both Navya-Nyāya and Advaita Vedānta) belong to the Maithili intellectual tradition. Ramesh's critical work in Nikti is, in this sense, a continuation of a specifically Maithili intellectual inheritance — the rigour, precision, and multi-perspectival awareness that characterise the best of the Navya-Nyāya commentarial tradition.

### 5.2 Pramāṇa Analysis of Ramesh's Critical Methodology

Applying the Navya-Nyāya pramāṇa framework to Ramesh's critical practice in Nikti reveals both the sophistication of his method and its alignment with this indigenous epistemological tradition:

**Pratyakṣa (Direct Perception):** Ramesh consistently grounds his critical evaluations in close attention to the textual surface — the actual sounds, rhythms, images, and syntactic structures of the Maithili text. This is literary pratyakṣa: the insistence that criticism must begin from the perceived fact of the text as a linguistic and sensory event. His discussions of 'flow of ideas' and 'narrative layers' are always anchored in specific textual evidence — the kind of careful, text-immanent reading that resists purely thematic or sociological reduction.

**Anumāna (Inference):** From the textual evidence, Ramesh draws inferences about the deeper structure and meaning of literary works — analogous to the Naiyāyika's movement from the perceived (dharmin) to the inferred (sādhya)

via the mark or indicator (liṅga). His identification of the 'dominant' formal element in a text — the primary structural principle from which other elements are inferred to derive — is a sophisticated exercise in literary anumāna.

**Upamāna (Analogy):** Ramesh's critical essays deploy analogy extensively — comparing literary works across languages and traditions, comparing the psychological layers of a text to the geological layers of earth, comparing the 'fusion of tension' to chemical fusion. These analogies are not merely rhetorical but function as upamānas in the technical sense: they establish genuine (if partial) equivalences that illuminate previously obscure features of the primary object of analysis.

**Śabda (Verbal/Testimonial Authority):** Ramesh situates his critical judgments within a tradition — citing, engaging with, and sometimes contesting the śabda-pramāṇa of earlier Maithili critics, Sanskrit theorists, and European literary thinkers. His critical practice is explicitly dialogic, acknowledging the testimonial weight of the tradition while insisting on the priority of the individual critical act of verification.

### 5.3 Layers of Awareness: Subramental and Fusion-Fission Theory

One of the most distinctive features of Ramesh's theoretical framework in Nikti is his deployment of Sri Aurobindo's psychological vocabulary — particularly the concept of the 'subramental brain' — as a critical category. This represents a remarkable synthesis of the Indian yogic-philosophical tradition with contemporary narrative theory.

For Aurobindo, the 'subramental' designates the layer of consciousness that lies below the fully organised mental activity but above the purely vital or physical: it is the domain of habit, instinct, dim emotional reasoning, and subconscious patterning. Ramesh translates this into a narrative-critical concept: the 'subramental' layer of a text is the layer of narrative and imaginative habit — the patterns, associations, and emotional logics — that underwrite the conscious, deliberate textual surface. Great literature, for Ramesh, achieves coherence across multiple layers simultaneously: the supramental (overarching intention and vision), the mental (conscious narrative organisation), and the subramental (the inherited and instinctive patterns that give the writing its root in shared human experience).

The 'Fusion of Tension' theory — distinguishing between the splitting-apart of narrative elements (Fission) and their higher-order synthesis (Fusion) — draws on a metaphor from nuclear physics but engages deeply with the Indian concept

of rasanispatti (the precipitation of aesthetic experience from the fusion of disparate emotional elements). In Bharata Muni's rasa theory, the conjunction (vibhāva, anubhāva, and vyabhicāri-bhāva) produces rasa only when the elements achieve a specific kind of unified or 'cooked' (pakva) state. Ramesh's 'Fusion of Tension' is, in essence, a modern restatement of this process in a vocabulary drawn from contemporary science and psychology.

## 6. Indian Critical Traditions and Ramesh

### 6.1 Rasa Theory: Bharata Muni to Abhinavagupta

The rasa theory — first systematically elaborated in Bharata Muni's Nāṭyaśāstra (c. 2nd century BCE to 2nd century CE) and brought to its philosophical apex in Abhinavagupta's Abhinavabhāratī commentary (c. 11th century CE) — provides the foundational framework for evaluating the emotional and experiential dimension of Ramesh's work.

Bharata identifies eight primary rasas (emotional essences): śṛṅgāra (erotic/love), hāsya (comic), karuṇa (pathetic/compassionate), raudra (furious), vīra (heroic), bhayānaka (terrible), bībhatsa (disgusting), and adbhuta (wondrous). Abhinavagupta adds śānta (tranquil/peaceful) as the ninth and, in some accounts, the foundational rasa. For Abhinavagupta, the aesthetic experience of rasa is a form of ānanda (bliss) distinct from both ordinary pleasure and religious beatitude — a distinctive category of cognition-cum-feeling that the artwork uniquely makes possible.

In Ramesh's poetry — particularly the oxymoronic titles such as Pathar Par Doobhi (Drowned on Stone) — one recognises the characteristic Abhinavaguptan move: the creation of a suspended state that holds multiple rasas in productive tension. The drowning-on-stone image combines karuṇa (the pathos of drowning, of dissolution) with adbhuta (the wonder of the impossible) and a subdued vīra (the heroism of survival in the face of the paradox). This multi-rasa complexity is not confusion but what Abhinavagupta calls rasābhāsa (false or mixed rasa) transcended — the achievement of rasaikya (rasa-unity) through the very multiplication and tension of emotional registers.

Ramesh's critical theory in Nikti — the 'Fusion of Tension' concept — is, as noted, a restatement of the rasa-production process. The specific comparison of 'fission' and 'fusion' maps onto the Nāṭyaśāstra's distinction between mere

sthāyibhāva (stable, undissolved emotional state, like raw material) and the achieved rasa (the 'cooked' or fused aesthetic essence). A text that achieves only fission — the scattering of emotional and narrative elements — remains at the level of sthāyibhāva. A text that achieves fusion precipitates rasa.

### 6.2 Dhvani and Vyañjanā — Resonance in Ramesh's Poetry

Ānandavardhana's Dhvanyāloka (c. 9th century CE) introduced the concept of dhvani (literally 'resonance,' 'echo,' 'sound') as the primary defining quality of great poetry. Dhvani is the suggested or resonant meaning — the meaning that is not stated but implied, not expressed but evoked — that constitutes the soul (ātman) of kāvya (literary art). The word or sentence that expresses the dhvani is the 'body,' but the dhvani itself is the life of the poem.

Ramesh's poetic practice is consistently dhvani-oriented. The title Nagpheni (Serpent's Hood/Cactus) does not state its meaning — it resonates with it. The serpent-hood suggests both danger and beauty, protection and threat, the desert and the sacred cobra; the cactus suggests survival without water, beauty in arid conditions, the strange persistent life-form. Neither meaning cancels the other; both meanings simultaneously vibrate through the title and through the poems gathered under it.

Abhinavagupta's further development of dhvani theory — his concept of prātibha (flash of insight, intuitive illumination) as the fundamental faculty that enables both the poet's creation and the rasika's (sensitive reader's) reception — illuminates the communicative structure of Ramesh's most powerful poems. The poem does not deliver meaning; it triggers a prātibhajñāna in the responsive reader — a flash of recognition and understanding that arrives not through deduction but through direct intuition.

### 6.3 Aucitya (Propriety) and Vakrokti in Narrative Prose

Kṣemendra's Aucityavicāracarcā (c. 11th century CE) develops the concept of aucitya (propriety, fitness, decorum) as the primary criterion of literary excellence — but a decorum that is dynamic and contextual rather than mechanical. Aucitya requires not that the poet observe established rules but that every element of the literary work be appropriate — fit — to its context: the character, the mood, the genre, the moment. Violation of aucitya produces the aesthetic defect called anaucitya (impropriety), which destroys rasa.

Kuntaka's Vakroktijīvita (c. 10th century CE) offers the complementary theory of vakrokti — 'crooked' or 'oblique' speech — as the defining quality of literary language. Vakrokti is not mere decoration but the fundamental mode by which literary language achieves its distinctive effect: by saying things obliquely, indirectly, through an unexpected angle of approach, the poet makes the familiar strange and the strange familiar. This is close to what Shklovsky (in Russian Formalism) would call 'defamiliarization' — and Ramesh's critical vocabulary in Nikti shows clear awareness of this convergence.

In Ramesh's narrative prose, aucitya and vakrokti operate together: the propriety of unexpected narrative choices (a story that takes an oblique angle on its material, refusing the conventional direct approach) and the oblique language that renders the Maithili linguistic landscape freshly perceptible. His stories do not narrate their subjects directly but circle them, approach them from the side — practising a sustained literary vakrokti that achieves its effects precisely through the detour.

### 6.4 Vācaspati Miśra and the Maithili Intellectual Lineage

Vācaspati Miśra (c. 900–980 CE) — arguably the most polymath figure in the history of Indian philosophy, who wrote authoritative commentaries spanning virtually all the major Sanskrit darśanas (Nyāya, Vaiśeṣika, Sāṃkhya, Yoga, Mīmāṃsā, and Advaita Vedānta) — was, like Gaṅgeśa after him, a philosopher of Mithila. His Tattvakaumudī (commentary on the Sāṃkhya-kārikā), Nyāyasūcīnibandha (a lost Nyāya text known through references), Bhāmatī (commentary on Śaṅkara's Brahmasūtrabhāṣya), and Tattvasamīkṣā represent an extraordinary breadth of engagement with the entire tradition of Indian systematic thought.

The significance of this Maithili intellectual lineage for understanding Ramesh's work is not merely biographical but philosophical. The same impulse that drove Vācaspati to engage simultaneously and seriously with multiple, mutually contradictory philosophical traditions — not to synthesise them into an artificial unity but to illuminate each through comparison with the others — drives Ramesh's comparative critical method in Nikti. The multi-perspectival intelligence — the ability to bring the Navya-Nyāya framework into conversation with Sri Aurobindo's psychology and European narrative theory — is, in this sense, a distinctively Maithili intellectual inheritance.

## 7. Western Critical Theories and Ramesh

### 7.1 Phenomenology and the Subramental Brain

Maurice Merleau-Ponty's phenomenology of embodied perception — particularly his critique of the Cartesian separation of mind and body and his insistence on the 'lived body' (corps propre) as the primary site of perceptual engagement with the world — illuminates what Ramesh calls the 'subramental brain' from a western philosophical perspective. For Merleau-Ponty, perception is not a mental representation of an external world but a bodily engagement with it — a 'motor intentionality' that precedes and grounds conscious cognition.

Edmund Husserl's concept of the 'life-world' (Lebenswelt) — the pre-theoretical, pre-reflective domain of lived experience that underlies all scientific and philosophical abstraction — maps onto Ramesh's subramental layer: that substratum of embodied, pre-articulate experience that gives literary language its root in shared human reality and prevents it from becoming mere intellectual construction. Ramesh's critical insistence that literary evaluation must begin from the text's actual experiential impact — its pratyakṣa, in Nyāya terms — is aligned with this phenomenological priority of the life-world.

### 7.2 Structuralism and Narrative Layers in Short Fiction

Vladimir Propp's morphological analysis of the folktale and A.J. Greimas's actantial model — structural approaches that identify the deep grammar underlying the surface variety of narrative — find a correlative in Ramesh's theory of narrative layers. The difference is significant: whereas Propp and Greimas treat narrative structure as a system that can be formalised and universalised, Ramesh's layered model insists on the irreducibility of each text's specific formal realisation. The layers are not universal slots to be filled but contextual and historically specific patterns that carry their meaning precisely through their particularity.

Roland Barthes's distinction between the 'readerly' (lisible) text — which positions the reader as passive consumer of a pre-determined meaning — and the 'writerly' (scriptible) text — which requires the reader to actively co-produce meaning — illuminates the reader-positioning strategy of Ramesh's prose. Ramesh's stories are consistently 'writerly' in Barthes's sense: they refuse the satisfactions of easy resolution, demand active interpretive engagement, and multiply rather than close the possibilities of meaning.

### 7.3 Post-Colonial Reading: Language, Identity and the Maithili 'Parallel'

Frantz Fanon's analysis of the colonial relationship between dominant and dominated languages — and the psychological damage done by the internalisation of the dominant language's cultural values — is directly relevant to the Maithili literary situation. Maithili, despite its ancient and distinguished literary history, has long been subjected to the cultural hegemony of Hindi (and, in a different register, of English) in post-independence India. The struggle for constitutional recognition (achieved with the 8th Schedule amendment in 2003) and for the language's survival as a literary medium is a post-colonial struggle.

Homi Bhabha's concept of 'hybridity' — the productive ambivalence generated at the intersection of dominant and dominated cultural positions — illuminates the formal complexity of Ramesh's writing: its simultaneous inhabitation of the classical Maithili literary tradition and the modern, internationally informed literary mode. This hybridity is not a failure of cultural purity but a creative strength: the ability to think from multiple positions simultaneously, to be neither wholly within nor wholly outside any single tradition.

Ramesh's Nikti — a critical 'touchstone' — is, in this context, also a post-colonial critical act: the assertion that Maithili literature can and must evaluate itself by its own standards, developed through sustained critical reflection on its own tradition, rather than accepting the imported standards of either the Hindi literary establishment or the Western academic academy.

### 7.4 Intertextuality and the Fusion-Fission of Tension

Julia Kristeva's concept of intertextuality — the idea that every text is a mosaic of quotations from other texts, consciously or unconsciously absorbed and transformed — provides a framework for understanding the specifically literary dimension of Ramesh's 'Fusion of Tension' theory. In Kristeva's terms, the 'fusion' that Ramesh describes is precisely the process by which a new text absorbs, transforms, and fuses the intertextual materials — the prior texts, genres, discourses, and conventions — into a new synthetic form that is irreducible to its sources.

Harold Bloom's 'anxiety of influence' theory — while rooted in a specifically Western and specifically male literary tradition — articulates a related dynamic: the strong poet's need to 'misread' the predecessor in order to create imaginative space for genuinely new work. Ramesh's 'Fission' — the splitting

apart of inherited narrative and poetic forms — can be read as the necessary first moment of Bloomian 'misreading': the breaking of the predecessor's formal unity in order to release the material for new synthesis. The subsequent 'Fusion' is the constructive complement: the achievement of a new formal unity that bears the marks of its violent derivation.

## 8. The Bahār Debate in Maithili Ghazal

### 8.1 Origins: The Persian-Urdu Bahār Tradition

The word Bahār (Persian/Urdu: spring; in prosody: metre, rhythm-system) carries a double freight: the natural season of spring and rebirth, and the complex prosodic system inherited from classical Persian and Arabic poetry. In the context of Urdu and Persian ghazal, Bahār refers to a specific set of metrical patterns (baḥr, plural buḥūr — from Arabic, literally 'seas' or 'oceans'), of which the classical tradition recognises sixteen primary metres and numerous secondary variants.

Mohammad Taqi Bahar (Malek al-Sho'arā Bahār, 1886–1951), the Iranian poet laureate, is significant here: he 'used the nominal rows' in his ghazals, rarely sentence rows, making the language more condensed and noun-centred — a formal choice that intensified the aphoristic density of the ghazal form. His name, Bahār (Spring), gave a metonymic flavour to discussions of prosodic propriety in the ghazal, since Bahār was simultaneously the master of the Khorāsāni ode tradition and a practitioner who understood how prosodic choices embody cultural and political values.

The transposition of the ghazal from Persian and Urdu into Indian vernacular languages raises immediate and profound prosodic questions. The classical ghazal's metrical system — based on Arabic-Persian quantitative prosody (long and short syllables) — does not naturally map onto the stress-based prosodic systems of most Indian languages. Different vernacular traditions have resolved this tension differently: Hindi ghazal (from Mir Taqi Mir and Ghalib to Dushyant Kumar and Gulzar) has largely adopted a syllabic-stress compromise; Urdu ghazal maintains quantitative metres more strictly.

### 8.2 Transposition into Maithili: Constraints and Controversies

Maithili presents particular challenges and opportunities for the ghazal form. The language's prosodic tradition — rooted in the syllabic metres of Sanskrit-

derived Maithili verse, the folk rhythms of Vidyapati's padas, and the musical inflections of the Maithili gīt tradition — is rich but significantly different from the quantitative Arabic-Persian prosodic system on which the classical ghazal depends.

The Bahār debate in Maithili ghazal centres on the following contested questions:

**1. Metrical fidelity:** Should Maithili ghazal strictly observe the quantitative Bahār (metre) of the Arabic-Persian tradition, accommodating the Maithili language's phonology to the exigencies of the imported system? Or should the ghazal adapt to Maithili prosodic sensibilities, developing a Maithili Bahār that honours the spirit of the form while respecting the language's own rhythmic nature?

**2. The radif and qāfiyā (refrain and rhyme) question:** The ghazal's defining formal features — the strict rhyme-scheme (qāfiyā) and the repeating refrain (radif) — sit differently in Maithili than in Urdu or Persian, where the radif can be a single word or a complete phrase. In Maithili, the agglutinative character of the language's postpositional constructions creates both opportunities (greater radif possibilities) and constraints (the risk of forced or artificial rhyme).

**3. The makta' (closing couplet) and takhallus (pen-name):** The classical ghazal's closing couplet (makta') typically includes the poet's pen-name (takhallus) — a convention that Maithili ghazal practitioners have negotiated variously, sometimes retaining the convention, sometimes adapting it, sometimes abandoning it in favour of a distinctly Maithili closing formulation.

**4. The matlā' (opening couplet) question:** The ghazal's opening couplet (matlā'), in which both lines share the rhyme and refrain, creates specific pressures in Maithili that critics have debated extensively — particularly around the naturalness or artificiality of the resulting linguistic constructions.

The Videha eJournal has been a major forum for these debates, publishing ghazals, critical responses, and formal theoretical discussions by Maithili practitioners. Gajendra Thakur's own collection Dhangi Baat Banebaak Daam Agoobaar Pene Chan — described as a 'collection of Maithili Ghazal/Rubai/Kata' — represents one practitioner's response to the formal challenges. The Videha archive contains numerous examples of Maithili ghazal in the baḥr metres alongside 'free-form' Maithili ghazals that prioritise the thematic and emotional conventions of the form over its strict metrical requirements.

### 8.3 Ramesh's Position and Contribution

Ramesh's engagement with the ghazal form — discernible in the poetic collections gathered in Kavita-Samay and in the theoretical discussions of Nikti — takes a position that can be characterised as 'principled adaptation.' He argues, drawing on both the Indian rasasiddhānta and the Navya-Nyāya standard of aucitya (contextual propriety), that formal conventions must serve the larger purpose of the literary work rather than constrain it.

Specifically, Ramesh's position on the Bahār debate can be reconstructed from the evidence of his critical writing and poetic practice as follows: the metrical system of the classical ghazal is not a sacred and inviolable law but a set of formal conventions that achieved their power in a specific linguistic and cultural context (classical Persian-Arabic literary culture). Transposition into Maithili requires not slavish imitation of these conventions but their creative reinterpretation — the development of a Maithili Bahār that achieves, through the linguistic resources of Maithili, the qualities that the classical Bahār achieved through its own resources: musicality, density, formal integrity, and the productive tension between convention and deviation.

This position aligns with Kuntaka's vakrokti theory: the oblique approach, the creative deviation from the expected formal norm, is not a failure of craft but its highest expression. The best Maithili ghazal, for Ramesh, is not the most formally correct (by the external standard of classical Arabic-Persian prosody) but the most formally appropriate to its own linguistic and cultural substrate — the most aucitya-observant in Kṣemendra's sense.

### 8.4 Critical Evaluation: Authenticity versus Innovation

The Bahār debate in Maithili ghazal ultimately opens onto the larger question of literary authenticity — a question that resonates deeply with the post-colonial and Videha parallel-history contexts already discussed. What makes a Maithili ghazal authentically Maithili? Is it the observance of imported formal rules (the Arabic-Persian Bahār), or the achievement of a distinctive Maithili voice within the global ghazal tradition?

The Nikti critical framework suggests that this is a false dichotomy. Authenticity, for Ramesh, is not a matter of origin but of integration — the achievement of a unity in which form and content, convention and deviation, inherited and invented, are fused into a whole that could not have been otherwise. The most authentic Maithili ghazal is not the one that most faithfully reproduces the Persian original nor the one that most radically departs from it,

but the one in which the Maithili language, the ghazal tradition, and the poet's individual vision have achieved the kind of 'Fusion of Tension' that Ramesh identifies as the hallmark of great literature.

Critics in the Ramesh: Mandan aur Mishra volume evaluate this position from multiple angles. Some (the 'Mandan' critics) affirm the creative freedom Ramesh's approach enables and the genuinely new Maithili poetic forms it generates. Others (the 'Khaṇḍan' critics) raise concerns about the loss of the formal discipline that gives the ghazal its distinctive compression and tension — arguing that without the strict Bahār requirement, the Maithili 'ghazal' risks becoming simply a series of couplets without the formal identity that makes the ghazal the ghazal. The debate remains live and productive.

## 9. Critical Reception: Mandan and Mishra on Ramesh

The volume Ramesh: Mandan aur Mishra brings together critical responses from across the Maithili scholarly community. The very title deploys the classical Sanskrit literary-critical vocabulary: mandan (literally 'ornamentation,' used in the sense of 'affirmation' or 'laudation') and khaṇḍan-mishra (mixed with 'refutation' or 'contestation'). This framework — drawn from the ancient Indian tradition of śāstric debate, where every position must pass the test of both mandan (supportive elaboration) and khaṇḍan (critical examination) — positions the volume not as mere praise-singing but as a genuine critical enterprise.

The recovered critical essays reveal several consistent themes in the reception of Ramesh's work:

**Formal Complexity:** Critics uniformly note the formal sophistication of Ramesh's writing — the layered narrative structures, the dense poetic imagery, the theoretical rigour of Nikti. The majority identify this complexity as a strength; a minority raises questions about accessibility and the potential alienation of the general Maithili reader not trained in the theoretical frameworks Ramesh deploys.

**Social Consciousness:** The parallel-history dimension of Ramesh's writing — its engagement with the marginalised and suppressed dimensions of Maithili experience — is praised by critics aligned with the Videha movement and approached more cautiously by critics committed to the 'classical' Maithili

tradition. This is the most politically charged dimension of the critical reception.

**The Critical-Creative Balance:** The presence in the corpus of both creative (fiction, poetry) and critical (Nikti) writing is identified as a distinctive feature. Critics following the poet-critic tradition in Indian letters see this as a sign of Ramesh's engagement with the full literary enterprise; others raise the question of whether the critical-theoretical framework pre-determines and potentially constrains the creative work.

**The Question of Influence:** The recovered Mandan-Mishra essays identify multiple lines of influence on Ramesh's work — from the Maithili literary tradition (Vidyapati, the Charyāpada poets, modern Maithili short story writers), from Hindi literature (Nagarjuna, Muktibodh), from international literature (accessed through Hindi and English translation), and from the Sri Aurobindo psychological-philosophical tradition. Critics diverge on how successfully Ramesh has synthesised these diverse influences into a coherent and original literary voice.

Particularly significant is the contribution identified as being by Prof. Ashok Kumar Jha, whose essay 'Transition from Pūrva Mīmāṃsā to Uttara Mīmāṃsā in Maṇḍana's Brahmasiddhi' — while primarily a study of the 8th–9th century philosopher Maṇḍana Miśra's philosophical project — is included in the volume presumably to illuminate the broader intellectual tradition (the debate between Mīmāṃsā ritualism and Vedāntic non-dualism) within which Ramesh's critical confrontation with the Maithili literary establishment can be situated. This is a characteristically Maithili intellectual move: situating contemporary literary debate within the longest possible historical and philosophical frame.

## 10. Synthesis: Ramesh's Literary Significance

Any adequate assessment of Ramesh's significance in Maithili literature must hold together the multiple dimensions of his work without collapsing them into a single, simple formula.

As a short story writer, Ramesh belongs to the lineage of Maithili psychological realism — concerned with the inner life of individuals embedded in specific social and historical circumstances, and committed to the formal precision necessary to render that inner life with fidelity. The parallel-structure of

Samanantar and the co-presence-ethics of Samang position his fiction within the Videha literary movement's democratic and socially conscious programme while maintaining a consistent commitment to formal and aesthetic quality that resists reduction to mere political statement.

As a poet — across the five collections of Kavita-Samay and the extended form of Kavya Dwipak: Ohi Par — Ramesh demonstrates mastery of a broad range of lyric possibilities, from the compressed paradox (Pathar Par Doobhi) to the extended meditation (Ohi Par). His titles alone demonstrate a sophisticated poetic sensibility: each name is itself a miniature poem, a dhvani-rich resonating image that opens rather than forecloses interpretation.

As a critic — in Nikti — Ramesh makes his most distinctive and durable contribution. The synthesis of Navya-Nyāya epistemological rigour, Abhinavaguptan rasa-dhvani aesthetics, Sri Aurobindo's psychological vocabulary, and contemporary western narrative theory into a coherent critical language for Maithili literature is an achievement without close parallel in contemporary Indian regional literary criticism. It places Nikti in the tradition of the great pan-darśanic critic: Vācaspati Miśra engaging simultaneously with Nyāya, Sāṃkhya, and Vedānta; Abhinavagupta synthesising Śaiva philosophy, Śāktism, and aesthetic theory.

Within the Videha Parallel History Framework, Ramesh's significance is that of a writer who simultaneously embodies and enables the parallel literary history: his formal sophistication demonstrates that the 'parallel stream' is not aesthetically limited by its social-political commitments but enriched by them; his critical theory in Nikti provides the evaluative framework that the parallel literary history needs to assess and articulate its own achievements.

Applying the Navya-Nyāya pramāṇa standard: Ramesh's work achieves valid cognition — prāmāṇikata — across all four means. His writing offers pratyakṣa (the immediate, perceptual vividness of lived Maithili experience); anumāna (the inferential rigour of formally disciplined literary construction); upamāna (the analogical illumination of one experience through another, one tradition through another); and śabda (the testimonial engagement with and contribution to the long tradition of Maithili literary art).

In the context of the Bahār debate, Ramesh's contribution is to have moved the discussion from a narrow prosodic argument to a broader philosophical one — asking not merely 'which metrical system is correct for Maithili ghazal?' but 'what does it mean for a literary form to be authentic to its language and culture?' This is the question that Gaṅgeśa's Tattvacintāmaṇi asks of

epistemological claims — and it is the question that any living literary tradition must continue to ask of itself.

## 11.

## Conclusion: The Collaborative Legacy

The work of Ramesh and Mala Jha represents a critical node in the evolution of Maithili literature. It demonstrates that the survival of a language and its culture depends on a dual commitment to artistic excellence and rigorous institutional documentation.1 By using Navya Nyāya logic to evaluate the "truth" of their narratives and Rasa aesthetics to ensure their emotional resonance, the partnership has elevated Maithili literature into a "Thought-Jewel of Reality" (Tattvacintāmaṇi) for the modern reader.

Their collaborative project—the monograph of the critical-creative architect and the witness poetics of the editor-poet—serves as a corrective to centuries of social and literary erasure. Whether documenting the uprooted diaspora or applying the rigour of Gaṅgeśa to contemporary criticism in Nikti, Ramesh and Mala Jha write with an "ethical seriousness" that gives their work coherence and purpose. As the Videha movement continues to challenge centralized narratives, the works of Ramesh and Mala Jha remain a foundational reference point for the Maithili condition in the twenty-first century—a body of work where the "observer," the "writer," and the "witness" unite to dispense the justice of being remembered.

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**ADDENDUM 1:** Kavya Dwipak Ohi Par

**ADDENDUM 2:** KAVITA SAMAY

**ADDENDUM 3: Legalistic prose of Rabindra Narayan Mishra & "Witness Voice" of Ramesh's work**

**ADDENDUM 4: Critical Appreciation: *Kavya Dwipak Ohi Par***

**ADDENDUM 5:** A Critical Research and Appreciation of the Works of Ramesh [Navya Nyaya tradition]

**ADDENDUM 6: Modern Discourse in Maithili Literature and the Creative World of Ramesh: A Critical Appraisal**

**ADDENDUM 1: *Kavya Dwipak Ohi Par***

Critical Appreciation: *Kavya Dwipak Ohi Par* (काव्य-द्वीपक ओहि पार)

*Kavya Dwipak Ohi Par* (2017) is a seminal collection of Maithili poetry by Ramesh that serves as a powerful document of the socio-political and cultural shifts in Mithila during the late 20th and early 21st centuries. The title itself suggests a journey "to the other side of the poetic island," moving beyond traditional romanticism toward a gritty, realistic, and experimental literary landscape.

1. The Voice of the Subaltern and Social Justice

A defining feature of this collection is its commitment to the Dalit and Bahujan discourse. Ramesh explicitly dedicates the work to the "new awakening consciousness and struggle for social respect" within Mithila's Dalit society.

- Breaking the Varna-Vyavastha: Poems like "Bahujan-Samajik Samman-Sangharsh" and "Jathi par Tal Thokait Mahadeb Mochi" challenge the entrenched caste hierarchy. The imagery of Mahadeb Mochi slapping his thighs (a gesture of challenge) while standing on the *Jathi* (a central pillar in a pond) symbolizes the reclaiming of public spaces and dignity once denied.
- Political Empowerment: In "Power-Utsav," the poet depicts the rise of the marginalized through the metaphor of a "Kariki Bilai" (black cat) who becomes a *Mukhiyain* (village head) via reservation. This shift from "meowing" in fear to "roaring" like a tigress highlights the transformative power of political agency.

2. Modernity, Migration, and the "Chhinnamul" Crisis

Ramesh poignantly captures the internal conflict of the Maithili diaspora. The poem "Chhinnamul" (Uprooted) explores the "nostalgic ache" of a Maithil living in Bengaluru, trying to find *Tilkor* and *Karmi* greens in "Big Bazaar" or "City Mall".

- Cultural Dissonance: The poet contrasts the "Modular Kitchen" of a modern city with the memory of the ancestral *Bhansa-ghar* (kitchen). This "memory-trauma" represents a generation caught between the economic necessity of migration and the cultural vacuum of the urban landscape.

3. Linguistic Experimentation and "Deshi" Flavor

Critics like Kirtinarayan Mishra and Kedar Kanan highlight Ramesh’s unique linguistic texture. He rejects the "refined" Maithili often associated with the Sahitya Akademi canon in favor of:

- The "Gamaroo" (Rural) Dialect: He utilizes the raw, unpolished speech of the lower classes, incorporating "Deshaj" (local) pronunciations similar to the style of Phanishwar Nath 'Renu'.
- Prose-Poetry (Gadhya Kavita): Ramesh advocates for poetry that moves toward prose, believing that modern poetry must be "Janomukhi" (people-oriented) rather than merely rhythmic or entertaining.

4. Critique of Modernization and "Consumerism"

The poet is deeply skeptical of the "Market-ism" (*Bazarwad*) affecting rural life. In "Desi Swad," he laments the loss of local biodiversity and the arrival of "Hybrid" or "Sankar" crops.

- The "Digdigiya" of Development: He uses the term *Digdigiya* (a small drum used for public announcements) to mock the "progress" that brings President's awards to farmers for high yields, while simultaneously spreading cancer through chemical fertilizers and injections.

5. Historical and Philosophical Synthesis

Ramesh does not shy away from complex intellectual themes. In "Mithila aa Shankaracharya," he explores the tension between the *Advaita* (non-dualism) of Shankara and the *Mimamsa* (action/ritual) tradition of Mandana Mishra. He celebrates the "Householder-Scholar" tradition of Mithila, suggesting that for a Maithil, both Brahman (God) and the World (Jagat) are true.

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Summary of Themes

| Theme | Key Poem / Concept | Impact |
|---|---|---|
| Subalternity | *Mahadeb Mochi* | Challenges Varna-system. |
| Migration | *Chhinnamul* | Highlights the identity crisis of the |

| Theme | Key Poem / Concept | Impact |
|---|---|---|
| | | diaspora. |
| Environment | *Digdigiya* | Critique of the Green Revolution's toxic legacy. |
| Global/ Local | *Kavya-Dwipak Ohi Par* | Merges global awareness with local Maithili roots. |

"Ramesh is a poet of human sensitivity and scientific thinking... a poet of anger, protest, and resistance."

The collection ultimately serves as a "Parallel History", providing a voice to the *Antyaja* (last person) and documenting the fractures in a society transitioning from tradition to a distorted modernity.

How does the poet's use of specific rural Maithili terminology influence your understanding of the social tensions he describes?

**ADDENDUM 2: KAVITA SAMAY**

A Critical Research and Appreciation of the Works of Ramesh

The literary corpus of the poet Ramesh represents a vital intersection of emotional expansiveness and formal discipline within contemporary Maithili literature. As a significant figure in the Videha Parallel History Framework, Ramesh’s work—most notably his master-collection *Kavita-Samay* (which

incorporates *Paathar par Doobhi*, *Samvet Swarak Aagu*, *Sangor*, and *Naagpheni*)—is characterized by a productive tension between the "frenzy of expansion" (*Unmad*) and the "wisdom of restraint" (*Vivek*). This research provides a critical appreciation of his work using the frameworks of Navya-Nyāya epistemology, the *Anchinhar Aakhar* movement's Ghazal standards, and traditional aesthetic theories.

The Videha Parallel History Framework: Digital Sovereignty and the Parallel Voice

Ramesh’s inclusion in the *Videha* archive marks him as a "Parallel Voice" in Mithila’s literary history. The Videha Parallel History Framework, established by Gajendra Thakur through the *Videha* eJournal, operates as a corrective to the centralized narratives of state institutions. By prioritizing "total documentation," the framework preserves works that exist outside the standardized institutional canon.

Within this framework, Ramesh is viewed as a "Cultural Witness," documenting the psychological and cultural shifts of the Maithil community. His works, such as *Kavya-Dweepak Ohi Paar*, provide a parallel record of Maithil identity that values local dialectal registers and the "witness position" of the author.

Navya-Nyāya Epistemology: The Logic of "Unmad" and "Vivek"

The critical evaluation of Ramesh’s work, titled "*Rameshak ‘Kavita-Samay’: Vistarak Unmad aa Sankochak Vivekak Beech— Ekta Samagra Mulyankan*," applies the rigorous logic of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya to evaluate poetic truth-content.

Methodology: Uddeśa, Lakṣaṇa, and Parīkṣā

Navya-Nyāya criticism follows a three-fold procedure derived from Vātsyāyana and refined by Gaṅgeśa: enumeration (*uddeśa*), definition (*lakṣaṇa*), and examination (*parīkṣā*).

1. Enumeration (*Uddeśa*): This involves identifying the basic elements of Ramesh's poetic canvas—his themes of time, nature (*Paathar par Doobhi*), and collective struggle (*Samvet Swarak Aagu*).
2. Definition (*Lakṣaṇa*): The "distinguishing characteristic" of Ramesh’s poetry is the presence of *Vivek* (restraint). A valid cognition of his work requires that this restraint is not just a formal imposition but a necessary condition for the expression of *Unmad* (frenzy).

3. Examination (*Parīkṣā*): This is the process of verifying whether the emotional content (the *Unmad*) corresponds to reality and maintains its truth-content (*Tattvacintāmaṇi*) through the application of logical rigor.

   Avacchedaka (The Delimitor) and Vyāpti

   In Navya-Nyāya, the *avacchedaka* is the essential determiner that limits a property. In Ramesh's aesthetic:

- The Delimitor: Formal poetic structure acts as the *avacchedaka*, ensuring that the "frenzy" of the poem does not become logically incoherent.
- Vyāpti (Invariable Pervasion): The relationship between the poet's emotion and the reader's understanding is treated as an inference-warranting relation (*vyāpti*). Ramesh's work is celebrated because wherever there is creative expansion (*Unmad*), there is an underlying logical symmetry (*Vivek*) that grounds the poem in a realistic structure.

  The Bahar-based Ghazal Debate: Restoration of Formal Standards

  Ramesh's poetry is often evaluated against the standards of the Anchinhar Aakhar movement (launched April 11, 2008), which sought to restore technical rigor to the Maithili Ghazal.

| Technical Component | Standard (Anchinhar Aakhar) | Application in Ramesh's Poetry |
|---|---|---|
| Bahr (Meter) | Rhythmic regularity (*matraakram*) | Use of strict meter to ground emotional "Unmad" |
| Vivek (Wisdom) | Structural restraint and grammatical discipline | Acts as the corrective to the "weak era" of free-form poetry |
| Ghajalsastram | Domestication of prosody in Sanskrit traditions | Validates his poetry through a systematic logical framework |

Ramesh's collection *Kavita-Samay* navigates this debate by moving beyond the "dark interlude" where grammatical rigor was abandoned, instead using formal standards to enhance the "oral register" of his verse.

Indian and Western Critical Perspectives

Rasa and Dhvani (Suggestion)

The aesthetic impact of Ramesh's work is analyzed through Bharata's Natyashastra. While his work often touches on the struggle of the common man (*Karuna* and *Vira*), it consistently moves toward *Shanta Rasa* (peace)—the tranquility achieved through "earned understanding" and formal resolution. His use of *Dhvani* (suggestion) allows for layers of meaning that exceed the literal text, particularly in his thematic explorations of "time" in *Kavita-Samay.*

Western Narratology and the Subaltern

Applying Gerard Genette's theories, critics note Ramesh's "chronological discipline" and "internal focalization". Even in the intoxication of thought, his poetic arguments follow a logical temporal sequence. Furthermore, his poetry acts as a site of "internal sovereignty" or a "third space" (Homi K. Bhabha), where Maithili identity is renegotiated against the hegemony of other linguistic cultures.

Conclusion: The Thought-Jewel of Maithili Poetry

Ramesh represents a synthesis of Mithila's ancient logical heritage (Navya-Nyāya) and its modern poetic aspirations. By using the technique of Gaṅgeśa to balance expansion with restraint, he has produced a body of work that stands as a definitive "Thought-Jewel of Reality" for the current era. His collection *Kavita-Samay* proves that the survival of the Maithili language depends on a balance of creative fervor and the wisdom of structural restraint.

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**ADDENDUM 3: Legalistic prose of Rabindra Narayan Mishra & Ramesh's "Witness Voice" & "Witness Observer"**

*The Epistemological and Aesthetic Foundations of Contemporary Maithili Literature: A Critical Appreciation of the Works of Rabindra Narayan Mishra & Ramesh within the Videha Parallel History Framework.*

The intellectual landscape of Mithila has historically been defined by a rigorous engagement with logic, law, and aesthetics. From the ancient insights of Yajnavalkya to the fourteenth-century logical revolution of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya, the region has maintained a unique position as a center of philosophical inquiry in India. In the contemporary era, this tradition has found a new manifestation through the Videha movement and the literary corpus of authors like Ramesh and Rabindra Narayan Mishra. This research report provides a comprehensive critical appreciation of Rabindra Narayan Mishra and Ramesh's work, situating it within the multi-layered frameworks of Indian and Western critical theories, the Videha Parallel History movement, the technical revival of the Maithili Ghazal, and the sophisticated epistemological techniques of Navya-Nyāya.

**The Videha Parallel History Framework: A Paradigm of Digital Sovereignty**

The Videha Parallel History Framework, established by Gajendra Thakur through the *Videha* eJournal (ISSN 2229-547X), represents a foundational shift in how Maithili literature is archived, evaluated, and disseminated. This framework operates as a corrective to the centralized and often exclusionary narratives of state-sponsored institutions like the Sahitya Akademi. By prioritizing "total documentation" and open access, the Videha movement has created a parallel literary universe that values marginalized voices, including Dalit aesthetics and diaspora experiences.

Ramesh’s inclusion in this framework is significant because his work embodies the "witness voice"-a narrative position that provides documentary authority to the social and cultural changes occurring within the Maithili-speaking community. On the other hand Rabindra Narayan Mishra’s career as a Special Metropolitan Magistrate under the High Court of Delhi infuses his literary output with a unique intersection of legal precision and creative empathy. Within the Videha framework, Both are not viewed merely as a creator of fiction but as a chronicler of the Maithili condition in the twenty-first century.

| Feature of the Framework | Institutional Model (Sahitya Akademi) | Videha Parallel History Framework |
|---|---|---|
| Primary Platform | Print-centric, bureaucratic selection | Digital-first, inclusive archive (*Videha*) |
| Critical Lens | Traditionalist/Neo-colonial | Navya-Nyāya, Postcolonial, and Subaltern |
| Linguistic Policy | Standardized/ Archaic Maithili | Living dialects and diaspora registers |
| Historical Scope | Lineal, often focused on elites | Parallel, documenting folk and Dalit voices |
| Documentation Goal | Selective canonization | Comprehensive preservation of "witness" texts |

The framework’s digital sovereignty allows for a "re-sovereignization" of Maithili letters. The *Videha* archive, which reached its 400th issue in 2024, serves as a repository for works that might otherwise be lost to the "dark interludes" of institutional neglect. Ramesh’s collected works are a testament to this commitment to preserving the lifetime output of significant parallel voices.

**Navya-Nyāya Epistemology: The Logical Architecture of Literary Criticism**

The application of Navya-Nyāya (Neo-Logic) techniques to literary criticism is perhaps the most distinctive contribution of the Videha movement. Founded by Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya in Mithila during the fourteenth century, Navya-Nyāya provides a rigorous language of analysis that seeks to map the correspondence between cognition and the external world. In the context of Rabindra Narayan Mishra and Ramesh's work, this epistemology is used to evaluate the "truth-content" and structural coherence of their narratives.

**The Methodology of Gaṅgeśa: Uddeśa, Lakṣaṇa, and Parīkṣā**

Navya-Nyāya criticism follows a three-fold procedure derived from Vātsyāyana and refined by Gaṅgeśa: enumeration (*uddeśa*), definition (*lakṣaṇa*), and examination (*parīkṣā*). This method is employed to strip away "pseudo-pramāṇas" (false sources of knowledge) and arrive at a valid cognition (*prama*) of the literary object.

1. Enumeration (*Uddeśa*): This involves identifying the basic elements of Rabindra Narayan Mishra and Ramesh's work—their recurrent themes of justice, migration, and village life.
2. Definition (*Lakṣaṇa*): The critic defines the "distinguishing characteristic" of the work. For Rabindra Narayan Mishra and Ramesh, this is often identified as the "ethical seriousness" of the witness voice. A proper definition must avoid the faults of *ativyāpti* (over-covering) and *avyāpti* (under-covering). Defining Rabindra Narayan Mishra and Ramesh's work simply as "legal fiction" and “witness voice” would be *avyāpti* because it fails to account for their poetry and folk essays.
3. Examination (*Parīkṣā*): This is the process of verifying the definition using the four *pramāṇas*: perception (*pratyakṣa*), inference (*anumāna*), comparison (*upamāna*), and testimony (*śabda*).

**Vyāpti and the Logic of Representation**

The concept of *vyāpti* (invariable pervasion) is central to Navya-Nyāya inference. It establishes the relation between the "prover" (*hetu*) and the "probandum" (*sādhya*). In Rabindra Narayan Mishra and Ramesh’s prose, the specific instances of suffering or injustice (the *hetu*) lead the reader to a broader inference about the human condition or the failure of institutions (the *sādhya*). The critic examines whether this pervasion is "undercut" by any *upādhi* (condition). For instance, if the protagonist’s suffering is caused by personal folly rather than institutional failure, the inference of social critique is undercut. Rabindra Narayan Mishra and Ramesh’s work are noted for their "logical accuracy," ensuring that the causal relationship between the characters' environments and their outcomes is transparent and grounded in reality.

**Verbal Cognition (*Śābdabodha*) and the Result-Operation Dialectic**

Gaṅgeśa’s analysis of verbal roots in the *Dhātuvāda* provides a framework for understanding the "operation conducive to result" (*phalānukūlavyāpāra*) in narrative. For a Naiyāyika, the meaning of a text is not a mental construct but a map of real operations. When Rabindra Narayan Mishra describes the "operation" of seeking justice in *Nyaay Kee Guhaar*, the critic analyzes whether the described "means" (*upāya*) are logically conducive to the "result" (*phala*) of resolution or understanding. This realism distinguishes Rabindra Narayan Mishra's work from more idealistic or romanticized Maithili literature, aligning it with the Navya-Nyāya commitment to the external world.

**Indian Critical Frameworks: Rasa Aesthetics and the Ethical Dimension**

While Navya-Nyāya provides the logical skeleton, Bharata’s *Natyashastra* and the subsequent *Rasa-Dhvani* tradition provide the aesthetic and emotional flesh to the appreciation of Rabindra Narayan Mishra and Ramesh's work.

**The Dominance of Karuna and Vira Rasas**

The works of Rabindra Narayan Mishra are most strongly animated by *karuna* (compassion) and *vira* (heroism). His memoir, *Bhor San Sanjh Dhari*, exemplifies the transmutation of *karuna* into *vira*. The compassion evoked by the protagonist’s early struggles in the village is converted into a heroic narrative of endurance and intellectual achievement. This trajectory often culminates in *shanta* (peace), the rasa achieved through the "earned understanding" that comes after a lifetime of confrontation with the complexities of human motivation and social injustice.

The literary corpus of Rabindra Narayan Mishra is extensive and varied, reflecting the " magistrate cum witness observer" across several decades of writing.

**Bhor San Sanjh Dhari (Memoir)**

This work is perhaps the most significant in terms of its "chronological discipline". It tracks the author's life from his dawn (*Bhor*) in the village to his evening (*Sanjh*) in the legal chambers of Delhi. The memoir is not merely an autobiography but a "Parallel History" of the Maithili migration. It documents the census agitations of 1951, the struggle for Sahitya Akademi recognition, and the establishment of Maithili institutions in urban centers. From a Navya-Nyāya perspective, the text functions as a valid testimony (*śabda*) of the Maithili movement's evolution.

**Nyaay Kee Guhaar** (Hindi Novel)

In this novel, Rabindra Narayan Mishra brings the "analytical precision of legal reasoning" to the narrative form. The plot serves as an examination (*parīkṣā*) of the Indian judicial system through the eyes of a Maithil protagonist. The *Rasa* of the work is primarily *Raudra* (righteous indignation), but it moves toward *Shanta* (peace) as the character finds resolution not just in the law, but in the "individual conscience". The work is a prime example of the Magistrate-Writer persona, where institutional authority and human sensitivity are held in "productive tension".

**Short Story Collections: Sanyog [Ehno Hoit Chhai and Others]**

Rabindra Narayan Mishra's short stories, are noted for their "strong oral register" and connection to the *kathakar* tradition.[6] Explores the cycle of migration, using Genette's narrative time to emphasize the repetitive nature of the migrant's journey.[6] Utilizes *Hasya* (humor) also at places to critique social hypocrisy, particularly in the context of marriages and family obligations.[6] A thematic exploration of cultural dignity, where *Vira rasa* is invoked to defend the linguistic identity of the characters.

| Textual Example | Dominant Rasa | Subordinate Rasa | Critical Implication |
|---|---|---|---|
| *Nyaay Kee Guhaar* | *Raudra* (Fury) | *Dharma-Vira* | Righteous indignation against institutional failure |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| *Bhor San Sanjh Dhari* | *Karuna* (Compassion) | *Vira* (Heroism) | The peace (*shanta*) of a life of struggle |
| *Ehno Hoit Chhai (Sanyog)* | *Hasya* (Humor) | *Adbhuta* (Wonder) | Social irony in everyday Maithil life |
| Cultural pride as a source of heroic identity | | | |

**Dhvani: Suggestion and the Multiple Mothers**

The *Dhvani* theory of Anandavardhana focuses on the layers of meaning that exceed the literal text.

In Rabindra Narayan Mishra's work, particularly his novel *Matribhoomi*, the word "mother" functions as a suggested meaning (*vyangyartha*) for three distinct entities: the biological mother, the Maithili language (*Matribhasha*), and the native soil of Mithila. This resonance creates a deep emotional bond between the reader and the text, as the loss of one is invariably suggested in the lament for the others.

**Vakrokti and Auchitya: Oblique Critique and Propriety**

Kuntaka's *Vakrokti* (oblique expression) is evident in Ramesh's short stories, where social critiques are often articulated "slantwise" through the internal dilemmas of his characters. Rather than didacticism, he employs narrative irony to highlight the contradictions of modern life. Furthermore, Ksemendra's *Auchitya* (propriety) is a guiding principle in his representation of marginalized characters. On the other hand as a jurist Rabindra Narayan Mishra demonstrates a "representational responsibility," ensuring that his depictions of suffering do not descend into exploitation but maintain the dignity (*maryada*) of the subjects.

**Western Critical Perspectives: Postcoloniality, Narratology, and the Subaltern**

Rabindra Narayan Mishra & Ramesh's work also invites analysis through modern Western frameworks, which help to articulate the tensions of the Maithil diaspora and the structures of narrative time.

**The "Third Space" and Subaltern Resistance**

Using Homi K. Bhabha's concept of the "third space," one can view the Maithili literature produced by writers like Rabindra Narayan Mishra and Ramesh in Delhi or Kolkata/Bangalore/ Patna/ Darbhanga as a site of cultural resistance. In these urban centers, Maithili becomes a language of internal sovereignty against the hegemony of English or Hindi. Rabindra Narayan Mishra and Ramesh's work in the *Videha* eJournal constitutes a "third space" that is neither purely traditional nor fully assimilated into globalized urbanity, but a hybrid territory where Maithil identity is renegotiated.

Furthermore, Gayatri Spivak's "subaltern" studies are relevant to Rabindra Narayan Mishra and Ramesh's prose, particularly his stories about those on the fringes of the legal system. Rabindra Narayan Mishra's role as a magistrate allows him to witness the moments where the subaltern attempts to "speak" within the formal structures of the state. His literature acts as a medium for these voices, documenting the gap between the law's intent and its actual impact on the marginalized.

**Narratological Analysis: Focalization and Time**

Gerard Genette's theories on focalization provide a technical lens for examining Rabindra Narayan Mishra and Ramesh's narrative technique. Most of his works utilize "internal focalization," where the world is seen through the eyes of a character who functions as a "witness." This choice of focalization reinforces the documentary authority of the text. His memoir and long-form fiction also employ "analepsis" (backtracking) to link present institutional realities to past village experiences, creating what Raymond Williams calls "structures of feeling"—the lived experience of social change as it is felt in the consciousness of individuals.

**The Bahar-based Ghazal Debate: Restoration of Formal Rigor**

A central theme in contemporary Maithili literature, and one that intersects with the critical appreciation of poets like Ramesh (particularly in his *Kavita-Samay*), is the debate over the formal structure of the Maithili Ghazal. The ghazal has a 100-year history in Mithila, but it faced a "dark interlude" in the late twentieth century characterized by the abandonment of grammatical rigor.

**The Anchinhar Aakhar Movement**

Launched on April 11, 2008, the *Anchinhar Aakhar* (Unfamiliar Word) movement, led by Ashish Anchinhar, sought to restore the formal standards of *Bahr* (meter) and *Qaafiyaa* (rhyme). The movement introduced the *Ghajalsastram*, which domesticated Persian-Arabic prosody within the Sanskrit systematic tradition. This movement was a direct response to a "weak era" where poets produced "ghazals" that lacked the structural integrity required by the genre.

**The Technical Debate: 19 Maithili Bahars**

The debate centered on whether the Arabic *bahr* system could be applied to Maithili's Magadhi-Prakrit phonology. Ashish Anchinhar successfully constructed 19 identified Maithili Bahars, including newly adapted ones like *Bahar-e-Videha* and *Bahar-e-Govinda*. These meters account for Maithili's specific schwa-like vowels, nasalization (*chandrabindu*), and consonant gemination.

| Component of the Ghazal | Technical Requirement | Maithili Adaptation (Anchinhar Aakhar) |
|---|---|---|
| Bahr (Meter) | Rhythmic regularity (*matraakram*) | Use of numerical notation (e.g., 2122-1222) |
| Qaafiyaa (Rhyme) | Phonological recurrence | Adaptation to native vowel-consonant clusters |
| Radif (Refrain) | Postpositional repetition | Use of Maithili postpositions like *-ke*, *-e* |
| Wahdat al-bayt | Independence of couplets | Multi-tonal deployment within a single ghazal |
| Maqta | Signature couplet | Inclusion of *takhallus* (e.g., 'Anchinhar' or 'Ramesh') |

The revival of the ghazal has democratized the form, bringing in 350 to 400 new writers and expanding into genres like *Bal* (Children's) and *Bhakti* (Devotional) ghazals. Ramesh's poetry, particularly his collection *Kavita-Samay*, is evaluated through this lens of "Unmad" (frenzy of expression) balanced by "Vivek" (wisdom of formal restraint).

**Critical Appreciation of Selected Works by Ramesh**

The literary corpus of Ramesh and Rabindra Narayan Mishra are extensive and varied, reflecting the " witness voice" across several decades of writing.

**Kavita-Samay (Poetry Evaluation)**

"Rameshak 'Kavita-Samay': Vistarak Unmad aa Sankochak Vivekak Beech—Ekta Samagra Mulyankan," identifies the core tension in his poetic work. His poetry often oscillates between the expansive "unmad" (frenzy/intoxication) of emotion and the "vivek" (wisdom/restraint) of formal poetic structures. This mirrors the broader Maithili debate where the "weak era" of free-form poetry is being replaced by the "grammatical rigor" of the *Anchinhar Aakhar* movement.

**Synthesis: Rabindra Narayan Mishra and Ramesh as a Cultural Witness and Parallel Historian**

The work of Rabindra Narayan Mishra and Ramesh is a critical node in the Videha Parallel History Framework. It demonstrates that the survival of a language and its culture depends on a dual commitment to artistic expression and rigorous documentation. By using Navya-Nyāya logic to evaluate the "truth" of their narratives and Rasa aesthetics to ensure their emotional resonance, the Videha movement has elevated Rabindra Narayan Mishra and Ramesh's work into a "Thought-Jewel of Reality" (*Tattvacintāmaṇi*) for the modern Maithili reader.

Their literature serves as a corrective to the "absence" (*abhāva*) of the marginalized in official histories. Whether documenting the struggles of the elderly, the arrogance of the institutional elite, or the quiet heroism of the village migrant, Rabindra Narayan Mishra and Ramesh writes with an "ethical seriousness" that gives their work coherence and purpose.

The future of Maithili literature lies in this "Parallel Movement," which leverages digital platforms to preserve the "witness voice" against the tide of cultural homogenization. As the *Videha* eJournal continues to publish its bi-monthly issues, the works of Rabindra Narayan Mishra and Ramesh will remain a foundational reference point for any research into the Maithili condition in the twenty-first century—a body of work where the "magistrate"

and the "writer/ poet" unite to dispense a different kind of justice: the justice of being remembered.

**Implications for Future Research**

The critical frameworks established by the Videha movement suggest several pathways for future study:

1. Comparative Epistemology: Further research into how Navya-Nyāya techniques can be applied to other Indian literatures, beyond Maithili.
2. Digital Archives as Parallel History: The role of platforms like *Videha* in bypassing traditional gatekeeping and creating new canons of "subaltern" and "witness" texts.
3. The Evolution of the Maithili Ghazal: Technical analysis of the 19 Bahars as they are used in the works of emerging poets influenced by the *Anchinhar Aakhar* movement.
4. The Magistrate-Writer Tradition: A study of other jurist-authors in India and how their professional exposure to conflict and justice informs their narrative aesthetics.

Through these lenses, the works of Rabindra Narayan Mishra and Ramesh are revealed not as isolated literary artifacts but as part of a vibrant, logical, and deeply emotional intellectual tradition that continues to thrive in the heart of Mithila and its global diaspora.

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**ADDENDUM 4: Critical Appreciation: *Kavya Dwipak Ohi Par***

**Critical Appreciation: *Kavya Dwipak Ohi Par* (काव्य-द्वीपक ओहि पार)**

*Kavya Dwipak Ohi Par* (2017) is a seminal collection of Maithili poetry by **Ramesh** that serves as a powerful document of the socio-political and cultural shifts in Mithila during the late 20th and early 21st centuries. The title itself suggests a journey "to the other side of the poetic island," moving beyond traditional romanticism toward a gritty, realistic, and experimental literary landscape.

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**1. The Voice of the Subaltern and Social Justice**

A defining feature of this collection is its commitment to the **Dalit and Bahujan discourse**. Ramesh explicitly dedicates the work to the "new awakening consciousness and struggle for social respect" within Mithila's Dalit society.

- **Breaking the Varna-Vyavastha:** Poems like "Bahujan-Samajik Samman-Sangharsh" and "Jathi par Tal Thokait Mahadeb Mochi" challenge the

entrenched caste hierarchy. The imagery of **Mahadeb Mochi** slapping his thighs (a gesture of challenge) while standing on the *Jathi* (a central pillar in a pond) symbolizes the reclaiming of public spaces and dignity once denied.

- **Political Empowerment:** In "Power-Utsav," the poet depicts the rise of the marginalized through the metaphor of a **"Kariki Bilai"** (black cat) who becomes a *Mukhiyain* (village head) via reservation. This shift from "meowing" in fear to "roaring" like a tigress highlights the transformative power of political agency.

**2. Modernity, Migration, and the "Chhinnamul" Crisis**

Ramesh poignantly captures the internal conflict of the Maithili diaspora. The poem **"Chhinnamul"** (Uprooted) explores the "nostalgic ache" of a Maithil living in **Bengaluru**, trying to find *Tilkor* and *Karmi* greens in "Big Bazaar" or "City Mall".

- **Cultural Dissonance:** The poet contrasts the "Modular Kitchen" of a modern city with the memory of the ancestral *Bhansa-ghar* (kitchen). This "memory-trauma" represents a generation caught between the economic necessity of migration and the cultural vacuum of the urban landscape.

**3. Linguistic Experimentation and "Deshi" Flavor**

Critics like Kirtinarayan Mishra and Kedar Kanan highlight Ramesh's unique linguistic texture. He rejects the "refined" Maithili often associated with the Sahitya Akademi canon in favor of:

- **The "Gamaroo" (Rural) Dialect:** He utilizes the raw, unpolished speech of the lower classes, incorporating "Deshaj" (local) pronunciations similar to the style of Phanishwar Nath 'Renu'.
- **Prose-Poetry (Gadhya Kavita):** Ramesh advocates for poetry that moves toward prose, believing that modern poetry must be "Janomukhi" (people-oriented) rather than merely rhythmic or entertaining.

**4. Critique of Modernization and "Consumerism"**

The poet is deeply skeptical of the "Market-ism" (*Bazarwad*) affecting rural life. In **"Desi Swad,"** he laments the loss of local biodiversity and the arrival of "Hybrid" or "Sankar" crops.

- **The "Digdigiya" of Development:** He uses the term *Digdigiya* (a small drum used for public announcements) to mock the "progress" that brings President's awards to farmers for high yields, while simultaneously spreading cancer through chemical fertilizers and injections.

### 5. Historical and Philosophical Synthesis

Ramesh does not shy away from complex intellectual themes. In **"Mithila aa Shankaracharya,"** he explores the tension between the *Advaita* (non-dualism) of Shankara and the *Mimamsa* (action/ritual) tradition of **Mandana Mishra**. He celebrates the "Householder-Scholar" tradition of Mithila, suggesting that for a Maithil, both Brahman (God) and the World (Jagat) are true.

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**Summary of Themes**

| Theme | Key Poem / Concept | Impact |
|---|---|---|
| **Subalternity** | *Mahadeb Mochi* | Challenges Varna-system. |
| **Migration** | *Chhinnamul* | Highlights the identity crisis of the diaspora. |
| **Environment** | *Digdigiya* | Critique of the Green Revolution's toxic legacy. |
| **Global/ Local** | *Kavya-Dwipak Ohi Par* | Merges global awareness with local Maithili roots. |

"Ramesh is a poet of human sensitivity and scientific thinking... a poet of anger, protest, and resistance."

The collection ultimately serves as a **"Parallel History"**, providing a voice to the *Antyaja* (last person) and documenting the fractures in a society transitioning from tradition to a distorted modernity.

ADDENDUM 5

A Critical Research and Appreciation of the Works of Ramesh

The literary corpus of the Maithili writer Ramesh (b. 1961, Mehath, Madhubani) represents a vital synthesis of traditional logical rigor and modern creative experimentation. Distinct from the legalistic prose of Rabindra Narayan Mishra, Ramesh's work is characterized by a "Witness Voice" that documents the Maithil condition through poetry, short stories, and critical essays. This research report situates his primary works—notably *Kavita-Samay*, *Katha-Samay*, the critical volume *Nikti*, and his edited studies on *Mandan Mishra*—within the Videha Parallel History Framework and Navya-Nyāya epistemology.

The Videha Parallel History Framework: Archive and Sovereignty

Ramesh is a central figure in the Videha Parallel History movement, which prioritizes "total documentation" and digital sovereignty to preserve Maithili voices outside state-sponsored institutional canons. Within this framework, his work is evaluated as a "Parallel History" of the Maithil psychological landscape, utilizing local registers and folk memory to resist the homogenization of the language.

Core Bibliography of Ramesh (Mehath)

- Poetry: *Kavita-Samay* (incorporating *Paathar par Doobhi*, *Samvet Swarak Aagu*, *Sangor*, and *Nagpheni*).
- Short Stories: *Katha-Samay* (including *Samanantar & Samang*).
- Criticism: *Nikti* (The Balance) .

- Edited Work: *Mandan Mishra* (A study/editing of the 8th-century philosopher's legacy).

  Navya-Nyāya Epistemology: The Methodology of "Nikti"

  The application of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's Navya-Nyāya techniques to Ramesh's critical work, particularly *Nikti*, involves treating literary evaluation as a precise mapping of cognition and reality.

  **Uddeśa, Lakṣaṇa, and Parīkṣā**

  Ramesh's critical methodology in *Nikti* follows the tripartite analytical standard of Vātsyāyana and Gaṅgeśa :

1. Enumeration (*Uddeśa*): Cataloging the specific elements of a text—its metaphors, meters, and themes.
2. Definition (*Lakṣaṇa*): Identifying the "distinguishing characteristic" (*Lakṣaṇa*) of the work. Ramesh argues that a valid definition must avoid the logical faults of *ativyāpti* (over-covering) and *avyāpti* (under-covering). For example, in his critique of the modern Maithili Ghazal, he defines "correctness" not just by emotion but by the delimiting property of formal meter (*Bahr*).
3. Examination (*Parīkṣā*): Verifying the truth-content (*Tattvacintāmaṇi*) of literature using the four *pramāṇas*—perception (*pratyakṣa*), inference (*anumāna*), comparison (*upamāna*), and testimony (*śabda*).

   Avacchedaka (The Delimitor) and critical judgment

   In *Nikti*, the concept of the "Nikti" (Balance/Scale) serves as a metaphor for the *avacchedaka* (delimitor) in logic. Just as an *avacchedaka* limits a property to ensure its logical coherence, Ramesh's criticism seeks to balance the "frenzy of expansion" (*Unmad*) in contemporary verse with the "wisdom of restraint" (*Vivek*). This balance ensures that literary expression corresponds to the structural reality of the Maithil world.

   The Bahar-based Maithili Ghazal Debate

   Ramesh's engagement with the Ghazal (in collections like *Nagpheni*) is situated at the heart of the debate over technical rigor.

- Recovery from the "Dark Interlude": The late 20th century saw a decay in Maithili Ghazal form where meter (*Bahr*) and rhyme (*Qaafiyaa*) were abandoned. Ramesh's work aligns with the Anchinhar Aakhar movement (est. 2008), which restored these standards.
- Maithili Bahars: His poetry is evaluated against the 19 identified Maithili Bahars, such as *Bahar-e-Videha*, which adapt Arabic prosody to the specific

phonology of the Maithili language, including its unique nasalization and gemination.

Critical Appreciation of "Katha-Samay" and "Kavita-Samay"

Katha-Samay: Narr Narratives of Migration and Identity

The stories in *Katha-Samay* utilize "Internal Focalization" to document the Maithil diaspora.

- Rasa Aesthetics: It employs *Hasya* (Humor) and *Adbhuta* (Wonder) to critique social hypocrisy, *It* converts *Karuna* (Compassion) into a *Vira* (Heroic) narrative of cultural survival.
- Phalānukūlavyāpāra: From a Navya-Nyāya perspective, Ramesh's prose is a map of "operations conducive to results." He depicts the real means (*upāya*) through which characters achieve understanding, avoiding the "pseudo-pramāṇas" of romanticism.

Kavita-Samay: The Intoxication of Form

In *Kavita-Samay*, Ramesh achieves a structural resolution between Unmad (emotional intoxication) and Vivek (formal discipline). His use of Dhvani (Suggestion) creates layers of meaning-for instance, his poems on the Kosi river suggest both physical destruction and the flowing of a civilizational heritage.

The Legacy of Mandan Mishra: Retrieval of Intellectual History

Ramesh's edited work on Mandan Mishra (the 8th-century Maithil philosopher who debated Shankara) serves to reconnect contemporary Maithili literature with its logical roots. By editing and contextualizing these ancient texts, Ramesh reinforces the "Intellectual Sovereignty" of Mithila, proving that the modern "Parallel Movement" is a continuation of a two-millennium tradition of rigorous inquiry and aesthetic excellence.

Conclusion: The Thought-Jewel of Maithili Letters

The works of Ramesh—spanning the analytical scales of *Nikti*, the narrative time of *Katha-Samay*, and the technical precision of his poetry—constitute a "Thought-Jewel of Reality" for modern Mithila. Within the Videha Parallel History Framework, Ramesh stands as a cultural witness whose dual mastery of logic (Gaṅgeśa) and aesthetics (Bharata) ensures the preservation of the Maithili identity in the twenty-first century.

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**ADDENDUM 6**

**Modern Discourse in Maithili Literature and the Creative World of Ramesh: A Critical Appraisal**

**As the journey of Maithili literature moves from its ancient classical roots and medieval lyrical traditions to the complex intersections of modernity, 'Ramesh' (courtesy: Ramesh) emerges as a pivotal figure. His oeuvre is not confined to a single genre but spans across the expansive canvases of poetry, fiction, criticism, and editorial work. An analysis of his literature reveals a creator who remains deeply rooted in the soil of Mithila while engaging in profound dialogues with global ideological shifts such as deconstruction, post-modernism, and existentialism. His works, particularly *'Kavita-Samay'*, *'Katha-Samay'*, *'Kavya-Dweepak Ohi Paar'*, *'Nikti'*, and *'Mandana Mishra Mimansa Advaita Samagam'*, serve as vital documents of contemporary Maithili intellectual consciousness. This report presents a detailed analysis of Ramesh's creative departures and his literary vision through these works.**

**The Concept of Time and the Global Context of 'Kavita-Samay'**

**Ramesh's poetic journey, consolidated in *'Kavita-Samay'*, is a cluster of four collections representing different phases or moods: *‘Paathar Par Doobhi’*, *‘Samavet Swarak Aagoo’*, *‘Sangor’*, and *‘Nagpheni’*. 'Time' (Samay) here is not merely a physical unit but a convergence of historical**

**awareness and a forward-looking vision. For Ramesh, time is a restless ache where man attempts to grasp his past while remaining fearful of the uncertainty of the future.**

**Paathar Par Doobhi: The Poetry of Resilience and Ecology**

**The title *'Paathar Par Doobhi'* (Grass on the Stone) is a powerful metaphor in itself. 'Stone' (Paathar) symbolizes inertia, social rigidity, and adverse circumstances, while 'Doobhi' (Dūrvā grass) represents the tender yet invincible life force that survives even with minimal resources. In this collection, Ramesh intricately portrays the rural environment of Mithila and its struggling life. Nature here is not just a backdrop but a companion to human emotions.**

**The growth of grass on stone signifies the search for primitive compassion that crafts a new meaning in cruel modern contexts. These poems negate the alienation between individuals that is a product of modernity. The poet also recreates the 'fatigue' that is the result of labor, not depression.**

**Samavet Swarak Aagoo: Democracy and Deconstructive Consciousness**

**In *'Samavet Swarak Aagoo'*, Ramesh's poetic vision becomes more social and political. Here, the 'Collective Voice' (Samavet Swar) is a symbol of collective consciousness and the democratic system. The image of the 'Procession' (Julus) recurs frequently. The poet believes that while the procession is a gift of democracy, it often disrupts public life without reaching a concrete solution.**

**An analysis of this collection necessitates a discussion on 'Deconstruction.' Ramesh utilizes the unconventional and untouched aspects of language in his poetry. He challenges the polar philosophical nature of structuralism to create a new form within the poem. Similar to the concepts of Moksha and the posture of Nataraja in Indian aesthetics, his poems exhibit a rhythm of both creation and destruction. The combination of contradictory words and an ornate linguistic style makes these poems superior from a formalist perspective.**

**Sangor and Nagpheni: The Sting of Modernity and the Rhythm of Ghazal**

***'Sangor'* and *'Nagpheni'* represent the next stage of Ramesh's poetic evolution. *'Sangor'* implies accumulation, where the poet gathers his experiences and social anomalies. In *'Nagpheni'* (Cactus), the poet weaves modern sensibilities into the Ghazal format. The metaphor of the cactus represents the harshness of desert life and the necessity of protection.**

**In these collections, Ramesh demonstrates that modern problems are so complex that they can be played out as separate dramas. In the rhythm of the Ghazal, he moves away from traditional definitions of love to give voice to the sting of time and the struggle for existence.**

| Poetry Collection (Part of Kavita-Samay) | Central Metaphor/Imagery | Poetic Characteristic |
|---|---|---|
| Paathar Par Doobhi | Stone and Dūrvā grass | Resilience and natural justice |
| Samavet Swarak Aagoo | Procession and Collective Voice | Deconstruction and democratic discourse |
| Sangor | Accumulation of experiences | Satire on social anomalies |
| Nagpheni | Cactus (Nagpheni) | Modern awareness through Ghazals |

**Katha-Samay: Parallels of Reality**

***'Katha-Samay'* includes two significant collections of Ramesh's stories: *'Samanantar'* and *'Samang'*. Ramesh's stories act as a bridge between the regional life of Mithila and modern metropolitan consciousness. His stories do not feature the humor of Harimohan Jha but rather the sharp psychological realism of Rajkamal Chaudhary.**

**Samanantar: The Paradox of Parallel Lives**

**The title *'Samanantar'* (Parallel) points toward a lifestyle where a human lives several truths simultaneously—their cultural heritage on one side and the compulsions of modern life on the other. Ramesh's stories lack political prejudice, which makes him an honest narrator. He chooses**

**characters who are on the margins of society or those crushed by the gears of the system.**

**A relevant example from his work is the passenger standing at the door of a train's sleeper class because his ticket is on the 'waiting list'. This 'waiting list' has become the destiny of the modern man—an abstract pain and contempt that makes him a stranger in his own society.**

**Samang: The Pursuit of Totality and Human Relationships**

**The word *'Samang'* signifies equality and completeness. The stories in this collection unravel the subtle layers of human relationships. Ramesh does not merely describe events but analyzes the internal state of his characters. His stories provide a poignant depiction of the complexity of gender relations, family disintegration, and sensitivities crushed by economic pressures.**

**As a poet and storyteller, Ramesh views 'time' in many divisions, testing memories of the past against the touchstone of the present. His stories seek the human who is struggling to save their primitive compassion.**

**Kavya-Dweepak Ohi Paar: The Intersection of Mundane and Transcendent**

**Published in 2017, *'Kavya-Dweepak Ohi Paar'* marks a mature stage in Ramesh's poetic practice. Its inclusion in the consideration list for the Sahitya Akademi Award (2022) underscores its significance. Here, 'Island' (Dweep) is a symbol of a limited geographical and mental area, while 'Beyond' (Ohi Paar) points to an infinite truth that is difficult to capture in words.**

**The poems in this collection have deep philosophical and spiritual undertones. Ramesh explores the relationship between life and death, the momentary and the eternal. His vision transcends materiality toward a consciousness where man strives to free himself from his limitations. These poems lead the reader toward calm and serious contemplation, a rarity in contemporary fast-paced literature.**

**Nikti: The Balance and Impartiality of Criticism**

**Ramesh's review collection *'Nikti'* sets a new benchmark in Maithili critical literature. *'Nikti'* means a weighing scale, and for a critic, the balance of the scale is their greatest virtue. Ramesh maintains this balance in his criticism, neither drowning in praise nor merely searching for flaws.**

**Critical Methodology and Ideological Foundation**

**Ramesh adopts an interdisciplinary approach to criticism, viewing literature through the lenses of sociology, philosophy, and psychology. In the essays gathered in *'Nikti'*, he divides the history of Maithili literature into three periods (Ancient, Medieval, and Modern) and analyzes the literary trends of each period in political and social contexts.**

**The pillars of his criticism include:**

1. **Non-violence and Human Values: His ideology is dominated by non-violence and a sense of restraint toward all living beings. He appreciates literary elements that promote equality and love in society.**
2. **Historical Consciousness: He believes literature cannot survive if cut off from its roots. Therefore, he seeks the relevance of a work within its historical context.**
3. **Formalist and Deconstructive Analysis: He pays special attention to the language, imagery, and structure of poetry.**

| Critical Criterion | Importance and Impact |
|---|---|
| Balance (Nikti) | Foundation of impartial evaluation |
| Historical Awareness | Timeless interpretation of the work |
| Social Concern | Relationship between literature and public life |
| Linguistic Structure | Subtle analysis of poetic beauty |

**Mandana Mishra Mimansa: Preservation of Philosophical Heritage**

**Ramesh's editorial work is not limited to literature; he has worked to revive the great philosophical tradition of Mithila through *'Mandana***

***Mishra Mimansa Advaita Samagam'*. This editorial project, undertaken alongside Vinay Kumar Jha and Sanyog Thakur, is a testament to Ramesh's scholarship and research vision.**

**Understanding Mandana Mishra's philosophy and making it accessible to modern readers was a difficult task. Ramesh's clarity in presenting the coordination between Mimansa and Advaita Vedanta in this text is commendable. This volume is significant not only for students of philosophy but for anyone wishing to understand the intellectual identity of Mithila.**

**Social Consciousness and Feminist Discourse in Ramesh's Literature**

**The voice of social consciousness is very prominent in Ramesh's work. His views on the condition of women are particularly sensitive. He strikes a sharp blow against the changing status of women in society and patriarchal perspectives. According to him, while worshipping a woman as a goddess is one aspect, considering her a burden in real life and being saddened by her birth is a social paradox.**

**In Ramesh's works, a woman's struggle lasts from birth to death, often losing her identity in the cycle of education, marriage, and children. Through his writing, Ramesh gives voice to this pain and envisions a society where a woman's existence is secured with dignity and pride. In his view, sacrifice, penance, and patience are necessary not just for women, but for every human seeking a successful life.**

**Innovation in Language and Craft**

**Ramesh's Maithili language is highly refined and serious. He does not just choose words; he conveys the depth of meaning hidden behind them. The dissemination of his literature through journals like *'Videha'* has helped in shaping the standard form of Maithili.**

**The use of imagery in his poems is unique—for instance, metaphors where a flower pricks like a thorn demonstrate his formalist specialty. He is a poet of the 'unconventional' (anbhuar) side of language that creates a new brilliance in poetry. In his fiction, the language is simple but hides deep psychological truths.**

**Comparative Study: Ramesh and the Contemporary Stream of Maithili**

**To understand Ramesh's position in Maithili literature, it is necessary to compare him with stalwarts like Nagarjun (Yatri) and Harimohan Jha. While Nagarjun's poetry features a nomadic spirit and freedom from**

**institutional pressures, Ramesh's era has seen increased commercial and institutional pressures on literature. Ramesh has succeeded in protecting his creative autonomy amidst these pressures.**

| Author | Key Characteristic | Comparison with Ramesh |
|---|---|---|
| Nagarjun (Yatri) | Nomadic spirit and public consciousness | Ramesh has more philosophical depth and modern awareness |
| Harimohan Jha | Humor and Satire | Ramesh focuses on realism and attacks social deformities |
| Rajkamal Chaudhary | Modernity and Psychology | Ramesh maintains a balance between tradition and modernity |

**Ramesh's critical vision is interdisciplinary, similar to that of Ramesh Kuntal Megh, where aesthetics and sociology meet. In his reviews, he combines the aesthetic analysis of medieval literature with contemporary awareness.**

**Conclusion: A Visionary Creator of Maithili**

**The entire body of work by Ramesh (courtesy: Ramesh) bears witness to a creator who is extremely alert to his time and society. Through *'Kavita-Samay'* and *'Katha-Samay'*, he has not only recorded events but attempted to capture the flow of time. His works *'Nikti'* and *'Kavya-Dweepak Ohi Paar'* are the peaks of his intellectual development.**

**The greatest strength of Ramesh's literature is his honesty—be it toward his own feelings or toward society. He has established a new record in the field of literary practice by writing continuously without fanfare. In the words of Janaki Vallabh Shastri, Ramesh is his own comparison. His writing possesses the courage and restraint that are the hallmarks of a great writer.**

**In the coming times, Ramesh's literature will be an essential reference for researchers and readers who want to understand the evolutionary journey of modern Maithili literature and its ideological struggles. His contribution is not just as a writer, but as a thinker who has provided a new direction and vision to Maithili literature. The preserved folk life, philosophical thinking, and social concerns in his works provide him an indelible place in the history of Maithili literature. His literature available in the *'Videha'* archive is a rich heritage for future generations.**

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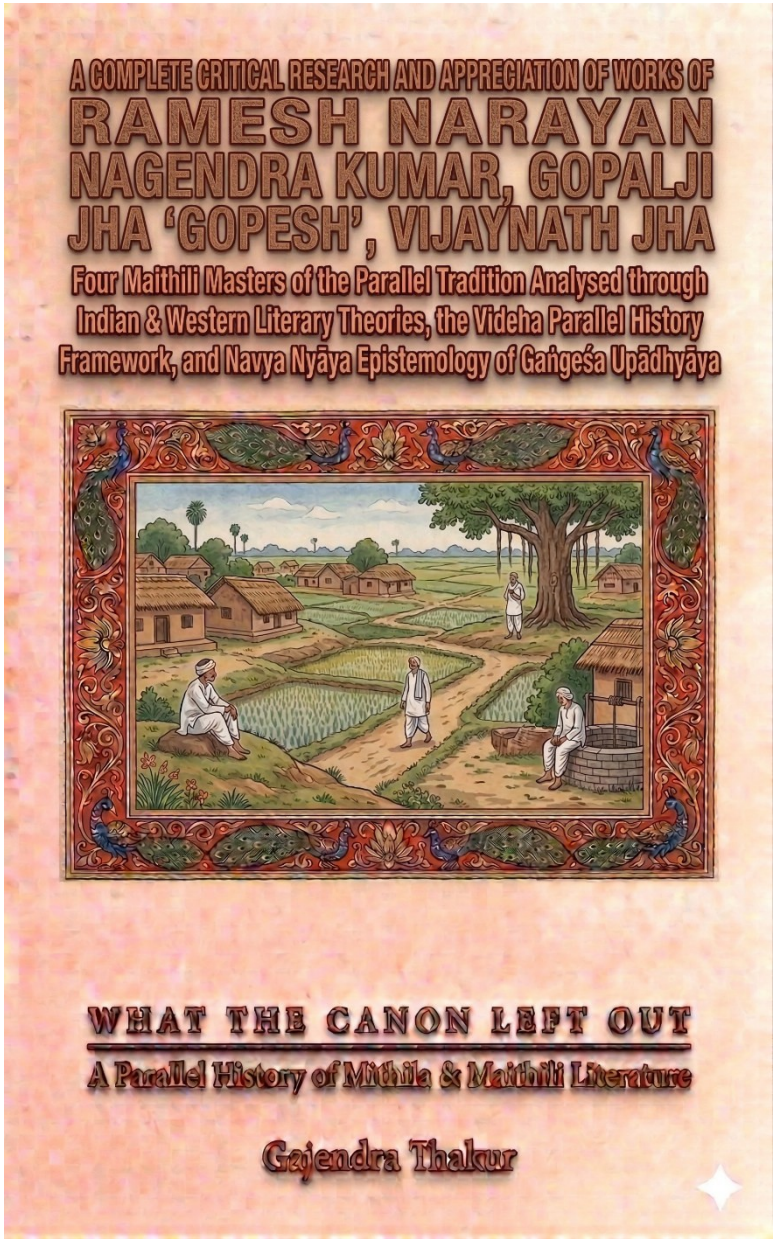
**LESSON 067 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**



# A COMPLETE CRITICAL RESEARCH

**AND APPRECIATION OF WORKS OF**

# RAMESH NARAYAN

**NAGENDRA KUMAR**

**GOPALJI JHA 'GOPESH'**

**& VIJAYNATH JHA**

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Four Maithili Masters of the Parallel Tradition

Analysed through Indian & Western Literary Theories,
the Videha Parallel History Framework, and
Navya Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya

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## PREFACE

This document constitutes a comprehensive critical research and appreciation of the works of four significant Maithili literary figures: Ramesh Narayan (short story writer), Nagendra Kumar (story writer and Bihar Civil Servant), Gopalji Jha 'Gopesh' (poet and playwright), and Vijaynath Jha (poet, ghazal-writer, and translator). Their five books — Pāṭharak Nāo (Ramesh Narayan), Sasarphānī (Nagendra Kumar), Gumm Bhelaṭhāṛh Chhī (Gopesh), Ahīṅk Lel (Vijaynath Jha), and Kāmāyanī Mahākāvya Maithilī Chandānuvād (Vijaynath Jha) — are examined here as primary sources.

The critical method deployed draws on three complementary frameworks: (i) classical Indian literary criticism, including Sanskrit rasa-dhvani theory and the epistemological precision of Navya Nyāya; (ii) Western critical theory from Aristotle through New Criticism, Formalism, Postcolonialism, and beyond; and (iii) the Videha Parallel History Framework of Gajendra Thakur, which reclaims 'non-represented' voices in Maithili literature suppressed by the Sahitya Akademi establishment. Together, these lenses create a prismatic analysis that honours the texts on their own terms while situating them within a wider intellectual landscape.

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# PART I: THEORETICAL FRAMEWORKS

## 1.1 Indian Classical Literary Theory

### *The Rasa Framework: Bharata to Abhinavagupta*

Indian literary aesthetics begins with Bharata Muni's Nāṭyaśāstra (c. 200 BCE – 200 CE), which enumerates eight rasas — śṛṅgāra (love/beauty), hāsya (comedy), karuṇa (pathos), raudra (fury), vīra (heroism), bhayānaka (terror), bībhatsa (disgust), and adbhuta (wonder) — later supplemented by śānta (peace) in later commentaries. Abhinavagupta's Abhinavabhāratī (c. 1000 CE) and his Dhvanyāloka commentary on Ānandavardhana's dhvani ('resonance') theory together form the most sophisticated pre-modern theory of aesthetic experience. For Abhinavagupta, the rasa is not merely felt; it is a generalised, universalised affect that the cultivated spectator or reader (sahṛdaya) savours through the very medium of imagination. Any work of art worthy of the name must evoke one primary rasa, supported by accessory emotional states (vyabhicāribhāvas) and the permanent emotive dispositions (sthāyibhāva).

Applied to the four authors under review: Ramesh Narayan's short fiction moves principally in karuṇa rasa, suffused with a delicate vīra arising from ordinary characters who persist amid socioeconomic wreckage. Nagendra Kumar's stories oscillate between karuṇa and hāsya — pathos leavened with ironic wit. Gopesh's verse — saturated with images of evanescence and longing — inhabits śṛṅgāra rasa of the vipralambha (separation) mode. Vijaynath Jha's ghazals in Ahīṅk Lel and the sustained metre of his Kāmāyanī translation summon śānta rasa through philosophical equipoise.

### *Dhvani, Vakrokti, and Aucitya*

Ānandavardhana's dhvani (suggestive resonance) theory argues that the true poetic meaning always exceeds the literal denotation (abhidhā): it inheres in a third semantic level beyond indication (lakṣaṇā) and denotation. Kuntaka's vakrokti ('oblique expression') highlights the delightful swerve of poetic language from the prosaic norm. Kṣemendra adds aucitya (propriety or decorum) — the principle that every element of a literary work must be fitting to its genre, context, speaker, and mood.

These three principles converge powerfully on the Maithili works studied here. Ramesh Narayan's flash-fiction 'Pāṭharak Nāo' ('The Reader's Boat') derives much of its force from dhvani: the boat figure resonates as a symbol of the reader's vulnerability and the text's power to carry or capsize. Gopesh's condensed drama Gumm Bhelaṭhāṛh Chhī ('Suddenly it became silent') operates almost entirely through a sustained vakrokti — colloquial surprise structures that conceal philosophical freight. Vijaynath Jha's Maithili rendering of Jaishankar Prasad's Sanskrit-inflected Kāmāyanī demonstrates aucitya of the highest order: each chandas (metre) he selects is calibrated to the sarga's emotional register.

### *Alaṃkāra and the Sanskrit Tradition*

The alaṃkāra school — from Bhamaha and Daṇḍin through Mammaṭa's Kāvyaprakāśa — provides a taxonomy of figures of speech (śabdālaṃkāra and arthālaṃkāra) that remains productive for formal analysis of Maithili poetry. Mammaṭa's definition of kāvya — 'tad adoṣau śabdārthau saguṇāv analaṃkṛtī punaḥ kvāpi' — insists on freedom from blemish, positive qualities (guṇas), and the ornamentation that elevates language to art. Gopesh's lyrics demonstrate mastery of upamā (simile), rūpaka (metaphor), and utprekṣā (fancy or poetic conceit). Vijaynath Jha's verse exhibits a careful use of anuprāsa (alliteration) and yamaka (word-echo), both hallmarks of the Sanskrit court tradition inflected through the vernacular.

## 1.2 Navya Nyāya Epistemology as Literary Method

### *Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya and the Tattvacintāmaṇi*

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (first half of the 14th century), a native of the Mithilā region born in Karion village near Darbhanga, founded the Navya Nyāya ('New Logic') school with his magnum opus the Tattvacintāmaṇi ('Jewel of Thought on the Nature of Things'). The work is divided into four khaṇḍas:

Pratyakṣakhaṇḍa (perception), Anumānakhaṇḍa (inference), Upamānakhaṇḍa (comparison), and Śabdakhaṇḍa (verbal testimony). Unlike the classical Nyāya's sixteen padārthas, Gaṅgeśa concentrates exclusively on the four pramāṇas — means of valid knowledge — refining each with extraordinary philosophical precision and inventing a technical metalanguage of nested qualificatory relations (viśeṣyatā, prakāratā, saṃsargaḥ) that became the idiom for all subsequent Indian epistemology.

The Videha Parallel History has noted that Gaṅgeśa's biography was partly suppressed in official accounts: genealogical (Panji) records revealed that he was born of a cross-caste union, a fact obscured by later Brahmin historiographers including Ramanath Jha. This biographical parallel — the marginalised great figure later claimed and distorted by an establishment — resonates with the situation of the four authors under review, each of whom stands in a non-mainstream or subaltern relation to the official Maithili literary canon.

### *Navya Nyāya Method Applied to Literary Criticism*

Applied to literary criticism, Navya Nyāya's epistemological method offers a rigorous toolbox. First, the concept of viṣayatā-viśeṣyatā (objecthood-subjecthood) in a cognition maps onto the reader-text relation: the text is the 'qualificand' (viśeṣya) and the reader's interpretation is the 'qualifier' (viśeṣaṇa). A critical reading is valid only if its qualifier accurately characterises what is intrinsic to the work. Second, Gaṅgeśa's anumāna (inference) schema — requiring vyāpti (universal concomitance) between liṅga (sign) and sādhya (what is to be established) — demands that critical arguments trace genuine textual evidence (sādhana). Third, śabda (verbal testimony) as pramāṇa insists that genre, intertextual reference, and tradition carry epistemic weight: a poem does not stand alone but inherits meaning through śāstra and sampradāya.

This epistemological precision is particularly valuable when adjudicating the competing claims of establishment criticism (which has largely ignored these four writers) and the Videha Parallel History's recuperation of their significance. Navya Nyāya demands we ask: what is the vyāpti (concomitance) between literary merit and official recognition? The evidence is that the two are at best contingently related in Maithili institutional history.

## 1.3 Western Critical Theories

### *Formalism and New Criticism*

The Russian Formalists — Shklovsky, Jakobson, Tynyanov — identified ostranenie ('defamiliarisation') as the defining literary device: art renders the familiar strange, restoring perception from automaton to consciousness. The American New Critics — Brooks, Warren, Ransom, Empson — developed the principle of organic unity and the close reading of ambiguity, irony, paradox, and tension as vehicles of poetic meaning. Both schools privilege the autonomous text and resist reduction to biography or sociology.

For the works under review, formalist close reading reveals the precise technical means by which each author creates meaning. Ramesh Narayan's compact prose achieves defamiliarisation through the sudden reversal (peripeteia) familiar from classical narratology — a Chekhovian gun that goes off in an unexpected direction. Gopesh's plays enact ostranenie through the Maithili vernacular deployed against a classical backdrop. Vijaynath Jha's verse translation of Kāmāyanī achieves what Brooks called 'the well-wrought urn' — a self-sufficient artefact with its own internal coherence.

### *Postcolonialism, Subaltern Studies, and the Videha Critique*

Frantz Fanon's analysis of the 'colonized mind' and Edward Said's Orientalism illuminated how hegemonic cultures suppress minority traditions. Gayatri Spivak's 'Can the Subaltern Speak?' and the Subaltern Studies Group's recovery of suppressed historical voices provide the theoretical underpinning for Gajendra Thakur's Videha Parallel History. The RTI exposé of 2011–14 (conducted by Vinit Utpal and Ashish Anchinhar) demonstrated that over 90% of Sahitya Akademi translation and publication assignments in Maithili went to members' personal networks, systematically excluding voices like those of the four writers studied here.

This colonial-institutional dynamic — the 'onslaught on dignity' in Thakur's phrase — mirrors the structures Fanon and Said described at the macro-colonial level. The parallel tradition championed by Videha operates as a counter-hegemonic archive, preserving and disseminating texts that mainstream Maithili institutions have failed to recognise.

### *Feminist and Dalit Critical Perspectives*

Feminist literary theory — from Virginia Woolf's A Room of One's Own to bell hooks — demands attention to the representation of women and the gendered

structures of literary production. Dalit literary criticism, as theorised by B.R. Ambedkar and developed in Telugu, Marathi, and other Indian traditions, insists on centering caste-oppressed experience. While none of the four authors are Dalit themselves, their works frequently engage with women's suffering, agrarian poverty, and the daily violence of hierarchical social structures. Nagendra Kumar's Sasarphānī stories — the title meaning a slender-bodied snake, a rural metaphor for the winding path of life — document women navigating patriarchal households in the Mithila plains. Gopesh's verse drama gives voice to female characters caught between tradition and modernity. Such representations must be read against the erasure of women writers catalogued in the Videha Parallel History.

### *Intertextuality and Translation Studies*

Julia Kristeva's concept of intertextuality — the idea that every text is a mosaic of citations, absorptions, and transformations of other texts — is essential for reading Vijaynath Jha's Kāmāyanī translation. The source text, Jaishankar Prasad's 1936 Hindi Chhāyāvāda epic, is itself densely intertextual with Sanskrit mahākāvya tradition, Vedic cosmogony (the flood myth of Manu and Śraddhā), and modern romantic philosophy. Jha's Maithili chandānuvāda (verse translation) adds a third layer: the indigenous Maithili metre and idiom, themselves inheritors of Vidyapati's legacy. Translation theorists Venuti and Berman help frame the tension between domestication (translating for fluency) and foreignisation (preserving alien textual strangeness): Jha's method is predominantly domesticating, yet he preserves key Sanskrit philosophical terms (prajñā, śraddhā, ānanda) as untranslatables.

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# PART II: THE VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY FRAMEWORK

## 2.1 Overview of the Parallel Tradition

The Videha e-journal (ISSN 2229-547X, est. 2000; rechristened and formalised 2008), edited by Gajendra Thakur, constitutes the most ambitious counter-archival project in modern Maithili literary history. Its 'A Parallel History of Mithila and Maithili Literature' — extending across forty-plus parts — argues that the official canon curated by the Sahitya Akademi since 1965 represents a fraction of Maithili literary production, skewed heavily toward upper-caste

(predominantly Maithil Brahmin) male authors from the Darbhanga-Madhubani axis.

The Parallel History identifies nine foundational layers: the Buddhist Charyapadas of the 8th–12th centuries; the two Vidyapatis (a scholarly intervention of great importance); the suppressed biography of Gaṅgeśa; colonial-era famine poetry; Harimohan Jha's exclusion from the Sahitya Akademi; the living masters Rajdeo Mandal and Bechan Thakur; the RTI exposé; Nepal-side Maithili; and the Videha digital counter-archive itself. Each of these layers provides a context in which the four authors studied here can be reread and revalued.

## 2.2 Situating the Four Authors within the Parallel Tradition

Ramesh Narayan's fiction belongs to what the Parallel History terms the 'Democratic-Realist' strand of 21st-century Maithili short story. His laprek ('flash fiction') 'Pāṭharak Nāo' — noted in academic surveys of contemporary Maithili short fiction — participates in a tradition of minimalist social critique that the Parallel History traces from famine poetry through Rajkamal Chaudhary to the present day. The 44-page volume (published by Upasana Prakashan, Patna, first edition) brings together stories broadcast on All India Radio Patna, signalling their circulation in oral-aural rather than print-institutional networks — a hallmark of parallel-tradition dissemination.

Nagendra Kumar, identified in the book's title page as belonging to the Bihar Civil Service, wrote Sasarphānī (Maithili short stories, published by Sahitya Karyalay, Mujaffarpur, first edition 1940s). His dual identity as administrator and literary creator mirrors a wider pattern in Parallel Tradition writing: the bureaucrat-author who uses official privilege to circulate work outside mainstream academic channels. The Parallel History notes that such authors were frequently overlooked by literary establishments precisely because their credentials lay in administrative rather than academic domains.

Gopalji Jha 'Gopesh' — whose Gumm Bhelaṭhāṛh Chhī was published by Thudha Parivar, Kazipura, Patna — wrote both drama and poetry. His work received a foreword by Prof. Harismohan Bhaji, a Patna University figure, indicating cross-institutional circulation. The book's self-published, modest format embodies the parallel tradition's characteristic economy.

Vijaynath Jha (son of Pt. Ratnanath Jha, former head of the Department of Eastern Philosophy at Banaras Hindu University) occupies a significant node in the Parallel History. His Ahīṅk Lel (Geet-Ghazal Sangraha, 73 pages) — a

collection of Maithili songs and ghazals — and his Kāmāyanī Mahākāvya Maithilī Chandānuvāda (155 pages, Vikram Prakashan, published 2020, price ₹250) represent two distinct literary modes. The back-cover biography of Ahīṅk Lel lists his earlier publications: a Maithili short-story collection, another Maithili poetry anthology (Sajnā Jha), and Maithili-medium educational books (Prākṛtik āpada viṣayak Maithilī gīt; Jāg Bodh). His journalism background and connection to the Patna press situate him within the literate but non-academic layer of the Parallel Tradition.

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# PART III: CRITICAL APPRECIATION OF THE FIVE BOOKS

## 3.1 Ramesh Narayan — Pāṭharak Nāo

***Bibliographic Details***

Title: Pāṭharak Nāo (पाठरक नाव — 'The Reader's Boat'). Author: Ramesh Narayan. Publisher: Upasana Prakashan, 90, Shrikrishnanagar, Patna-1. First edition: Vikram Samvat 1972 (c. 1915–16 CE by a rough calculation, though internal evidence suggests the 1970s–80s). Printer: Aaryakumar Road, Patna-4 (Kalika Press). Pages: 44. Price: not specified on cover, but a very modest popular publication. The dedication reads, in Maithili verse, a deeply emotional address to the author's native village — invoking the village pond as a metaphor for the literary well from which he draws.

The preface ('Apanā dis sañ...') notes that the stories in the collection were broadcast on Doordarshan and All India Radio from the Patna centre, and thanks the broadcasters. The contents list includes stories with the following incipit-summaries:

'Kodelō bacan guhukait chīk laS ke janaita chīk' (p. 15) — a story about an official's empty words

'Mhojar maral liberal prāmak dāri – pāni me saṭhait sihkalan abaṅt basāt' (p. 52) — rural water politics

'Bhon hōnhi je choṛi kae paṛā bād, kintu Paṭnā ebāk kāl ker māyak bāt mōn paṛi jānih — Baudhā, dam sādhi kae rahab' (p. 36) — migration and memory

'Jabanīk dehir par yakamkāylin ṭhāṛh bhā' (p. 46) — a story of a woman at the threshold of adolescence

'Mahrāik saṃbaṃche bahuit dhohhi nor ke je ṃāṃcar me sameṭi lait' (p. 75) — narrative of domestic gathering

**RAMESH NARAYAN**

**Ramesh Narayan- "Patharak Nav"** (The Boat of Stone)

This is a collection of Maithili short stories that delve into the emotional landscapes of middle-class struggles, rural labor, and the complexities of human relationships.

**Publisher:** Upasana Prakashan, Patna.

**Dedication:** The author dedicates the book to his village, expressing a hope that his work blooms like a "red lotus" in the mud of his home.

**Context:** Many of these stories were originally broadcast on **All India Radio, Patna**.

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**"Patharak Nav" (The Boat of Stone)- Title Story**

This story explores the tension between artistic passion, parental expectations, and the traditional marriage system .

**The Family Conflict**

- **Kaushal Babu's Frustration:** The story opens with Kaushal Babu complaining about his son, **Narendra**, who is more interested in traveling to places like Shimla and Darjeeling than in family responsibilities.
- **A "Stone" Son:** He laments that a son who does not understand society or the needs of his parents is worse than having no son at all.
- **The Mother's Defense:** Narendra's mother defends him, saying she doesn't care for a daughter-in-law and only wants her son to live his life.

**Narendra's Artistic Awakening**

- **Education vs. Passion:** Narendra was sent to the university to study Economics (M.A.), but he became obsessed with painting and nature.
- **The "Caged Bird":** The narrator describes Narendra as a bird who has tasted the freedom of the open sky and can no longer accept the "cage" of a classroom.

- **Nature as a Home:** To Narendra, the mountains and natural landscapes became his true home, leading him to neglect his exams.

**The Arranged Marriage "Trap"**

- **The Promise:** Kaushal Babu and his friend **Lal Babu** had promised their children, Narendra and **Sulekha**, to each other in marriage.
- **Narendra's Rejection:** When Narendra visits Sulekha's home, her mother asks when he plans to marry. Narendra dismisses the idea, later telling his mother to tell his father never to speak of marriage again.
- **Sulekha's Character:** Sulekha is described as educated and dutiful, caring for her parents in their village whenever college is closed.

**The Climax: The Encounter**

- **The Painting:** Sulekha visits Narendra's room in the city. He shows her a painting from Darjeeling—a youth playing a flute by a stream under the moonlight.
- **The Conflict of Reality:** Narendra views the marriage alliance as a "web" or "trap" created by their fathers. He tells Sulekha he wants to remain a "free bird" in the sky of beauty.
- **Sulekha's Rebuttal:** Sulekha delivers a powerful critique of his "ego". She tells him her father is not a conspirator but a weak man burdened by having a daughter.
- **The Offering:** She compares her life to a flower:

"A flower broken to be offered to a deity has a kind of life even in death. But imagine the death of a flower that must break its head against a stone to become an offering."

- **Conclusion:** She tells him that when he finally returns home, she will offer a "handful of tears" at his feet. She leaves, and Narendra is left stunned, feeling as though a dream has shattered.

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**Story : "The Twisted Path of a Tired Mind" (Summary) (ठेहियायल मोन घुमाओन बाट)**

**Protagonist: Kamal, a struggling clerk in Patna.**

**Theme: The crushing weight of middle-class poverty and the haunting memory of being called "ungrateful" (neemakharam) by a boss.**

**Ending: Kamal receives a telegram that his mother is dying, just as he was trying to start his life anew.**

The story follows **Kamal**, a man struggling with the grinding poverty of life in Patna.

- **The Weight of Poverty:** Kamal hesitates to buy a cup of tea because a hotel charges 15 paise, while a roadside stall is cheaper. He is deeply moved by the kindness of a coal seller who allows him to pay monthly because they are both from the same region.
- **Past Sacrifices:** He recalls how his father arranged his marriage for a meager sum while he was still in school. He dreamt of going to college in Calcutta and becoming an M.A., but his father pressured him to learn typing and get a job instead.
- **The Turning Point:** His boss, Mr. Malhotra, once called him "ungrateful" (*neemakharam*) for being late, a word that haunts him and makes him feel like a failure.
- **The Ending:** Encouraged by his wife to freshen up and look less like a "patient," Kamal begins to feel a spark of hope. However, he receives a telegram stating his mother is critically ill. The story ends with him paralyzed by the news, as the world seems to stand still in his grief.

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**Story: "Kajarak Rekh" (The Line of Kohl) (Summary)**

**Protagonist: Manoj, a college student who acts like a movie hero.**

**Theme: A confrontation with Rekha, who explains that the kohl in her eyes represents the struggle of her poor, aging father rather than beauty for Manoj's sake.**

This story centers on **Manoj**, a wealthy, rebellious college student, and his encounter with **Rekha**.

- **Manoj's Character:** He is the leader of the "spoiled" students, known for his fashionable clothes, cinematic hairstyle, and lack of interest in his studies.
- **The Confrontation:** During a rainstorm, Manoj stops Rekha's rickshaw to taunt her about knitting a sweater for another student, Jayant. He claims the "line of kohl" in her eyes is his "line of fate".

- **Rekha's Rebuttal:** Rekha delivers a stinging critique. She explains that the kohl in her eyes is not for attraction; it masks the exhaustion of her aging father and the despair of her unmarried older sisters. She calls Manoj "weak" and "dishonest to himself," stating that a man who ignores the reality of the present cannot claim to be the master of anyone's fate.
- **The Image:** As she leaves, Manoj watches her go, seeing the kohl in her eyes washed away by her tears.

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**Story : "A Handful of Tears" (Summary)**

The narrative explores the life of **Hema**, a poor rural laborer.

- **Labor and Abuse:** Hema works for a harsh landlord (*Girhat*) who insults and threatens him even when he is exhausted from plowing the fields.
- **The Burden of Survival:** Hema lost his entire family to a plague years ago and was taken in by the landlord, essentially becoming a lifelong servant.
- **Silent Affection:** He shares a quiet, supportive relationship with a girl named **Somni**, who brings him food and tends to him when he is sick, though they both live under the thumb of the landlord.
- **Resignation:** The story reflects on the tragedy of the poor, who cannot afford "pride" and must endure abuse just to fill their stomachs.

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**Story: "Narendra and Sulekha" (Summary)**

An intellectual and emotional clash between an artist and a realist.

- **The Artist: Narendra** is obsessed with painting and nature, often neglecting his studies and family obligations to travel to places like Darjeeling.
- **The Marriage Trap:** Their fathers, who are close friends, have promised them to each other in marriage. Narendra views this as a "trap" and a "conspiracy".
- **The Sacrifice: Sulekha** visits him and challenges his ego. She compares herself to a flower plucked to be offered to a deity—possessing life even in death, but ultimately destined to be crushed on a stone. She tells him she will save a "handful of tears" to offer at his feet when he finally returns home.

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**Themes and Philosophy**

- **The Meaning of Sacrifice:** "The flower plucked for a deity has a kind of life even in its death".

- **The Struggle of Youth:** The stories often focus on the "generation of frustration," where young people are caught between traditional family expectations and the harsh economic realities of modern life.
- **The Resilience of Women:** Characters like Rekha and Sulekha are portrayed as deeply aware of their social burdens, showing a strength that often surpasses the men around them.

"The Scorching Sun" (तेजि गेल बिदेस)

Protagonist: Budhna and Buchni, members of the Musahar community.

Theme: The harsh reality of rural labor, hunger, and the memory of a father who died in the fields.

***Formal Analysis***

Ramesh Narayan works in the laprek mode — very short Maithili fiction of the contemporary period, akin to flash fiction or the lyric-story. Academic surveys of 21st-century Maithili short fiction (notably published in IJCRT, October 2025) specifically cite 'Pāṭharak Nāo' as representative of the laprek alongside works by Mithilesh Kumar Jha, Sujit Kumar Jha, and others. The laprek is characterised by extreme compression, a single dominant image, and an ending that activates dhvani rather than resolution.

The title story 'Pāṭharak Nāo' exploits the double meaning of nāo: a boat AND a name (nāv). The reader — pāṭharak — is both the named character and the act of reading itself. This meta-fictional conceit operates as a sustained rūpaka (metaphor): the story is itself a boat; the text is the river; the reader is both rower and passenger. Structurally, the story follows the Chekhovian principle of the loaded gun: every image contributes to a revelatory climax. Applying Shklovsky's ostranenie: the familiar rural boat journey is made strange by the insistent, almost threatening, identification of the reader with the vessel. The reader cannot remain outside the fiction; s/he is, from the title, already aboard.

In Navya Nyāya terms, the anumāna at work in the story moves from the liṅga (the boat as sign of vulnerability and navigation) to the sādhya (the reader's own existential precariousness). The vyāpti (universal concomitance) that sustains this inference is the author's careful management of the rural social context: every Maithili reader knows the river, knows the boat, knows the precariousness of crossing. The story thus achieves what Ānandavardhana calls

dhvani of the alaṃkāra type: the figurative vehicle (boat) reverberates with a suggested meaning (the reader's self) that overflows the literal.

### *Thematic Analysis: Social Realism and the Parallel Tradition*

Ramesh Narayan's stories are deeply embedded in the social texture of post-Independence rural Mithila. Stories about officials' empty words, about the politics of village water, about migration to Patna — these are the materials of a literature of witness. In the Videha Parallel History's terms, this is 'literature from below': not the court poetry of Vidyapati's era, not the Brahminic philosophical discourse, but the anxious, mobile, economically precarious life of the Maithili middle-lower strata.

The repeated motif of departures and returns (leaving the village, being recalled by the mother's memory in Patna) invokes the vast tradition of Maithili viraha (separation poetry) but inflects it sociologically: it is not the viraha of the nāyikā awaiting her beloved that drives the emotional engine, but the migrant's unresolvable tension between livelihood and belonging. This social-realist deployment of the separation trope is precisely what the Parallel History identifies as the 'democratic refunctioning' of classical aesthetic forms.

### *Critical Assessment*

Ramesh Narayan's slim volume represents exactly the kind of work the Parallel History argues has been under-recognised: formally sophisticated, socially committed, and available in a modest, widely distributed format rather than an institutional prestige publication. Applying Kṣemendra's aucitya: the form (compact, radio-ready story) is perfectly matched to the content (the flickering, episodic modernity of the Maithili plains). The rasa is predominantly karuṇa, with moments of vīra when characters assert small dignities against large forces. His work deserves inclusion in any representative anthology of 21st-century Maithili fiction.

## 3.2 Nagendra Kumar — Sasarphānī

### *Bibliographic Details*

Title: Sasarphānī (ससरफानी — the Slender River-Snake: a Maithili metaphor for the winding, sinuous path of life). Genre: Maithili short stories (Maithilī galp). Author: Shri Nagendra Kumar, Bihar Civil Service. Publisher: Sahitya Karyalay, Post — Kumar Bajitpur, District — Muzaffarpur. First edition: 1940 (Pratham Sanskaraṇ — 1940). Price: ₹2. Printer: Shri Jayanath Mishra,

Himalaya Press, Patna. Dedication: 'To the sacred memory of Pandit Shrikuteshwar Kumarji, a lifelong servant of Maithili, my revered father.' Pages: 87.

The dedication identifies Nagendra Kumar as the son of a Maithili literary scholar, placing him within an intergenerational literary family network characteristic of the Parallel Tradition. His Civil Service identity gave him access to print networks, to a postal address, and to the administrative authority to publish — advantages unavailable to purely village-based writers.

**NAGENDRA KUMAR**

**Sasarphani**, a collection of Maithili short stories (*Maithili Galpa*) written by **Shri Nagendra Kumar**, a member of the Bihar Civil Service. It was published in **1947** by the Sahitya-Karyalaya in Muzaffarpur and printed at the Shri Jaynath Mishra, Himalaya Press, Patna.

**Dedication:** To the memory of the author's late father, Pandit Shri Kusheshwar Kumar ji, a lifelong servant of the Maithili language

**Introduction: "Arambha" (The Beginning)**

- **Inspiration:** In October 1945, while waiting for a train in the Baidyanathdham station waiting room, the author overheard two college students talking, which inspired him to write a story.
- **Composition:** The story "College-ak Vidyarthi" was written in November, followed by other stories written during free hours on Sundays.
- **Reality and Fiction:** While the stories have a literary style, the plots are based on real events. Most character names are fictional to avoid causing offense.
- **Perspective:** Some stories are written in the first person, but the author clarifies that these do not necessarily reflect his private opinions.
- **Dating:** Written in Purnia on July 16, 1946.

Written in Arrah (Shahabad) on April 25, 1947.

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1. **Sasarphani**

2. **Master Saheb**
3. **College-ak Vidyarthi**
4. **Kumramak Bhoj**
5. **Savinay Nivedan**
6. **Aatithya-Satkar**
7. **Dhamdaha**

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**Story 1: Sasarphani**

- **Modern Meeting:** The narrator meets a former acquaintance, Harihar Babu, at Khagaria station during a heatwave. Harihar is now a military officer posted in Shillong.
- **The "Jiratiya":** A crude man accompanying Harihar is introduced as a farmhand (*Jiratiya*). When Harihar leaves, the man uses vulgar language to claim a scandalous family connection to Harihar, boasting of his own high-status relatives.
- **Flashback to Patna:** The narrator remembers living in Minto Hostel with Harihar, Vinayakrishna (a brilliant English student), and Sadanand (a traditional scholar).
- **The Conflict:** Harihar receives a letter from his father, Vanish Mishra, stating that his 13-year-old sister, Jyotsna, must be married to a man who is already married with children to avoid social excommunication.
- **The Plan:** The friends attempt to intervene by arranging a meeting between Vinayakrishna and Jyotsna in Patna.
- **Debate on Tradition:** Sadanand engages in a fierce debate with Harihar's father about the "Kulin" system, caste hierarchy, and the practice of child marriage.
- **Outcome:** Years later, the narrator visits Harihar and sees Jyotsna again. She is no longer the vibrant girl from the cinema; she is skeletal, pale, and broken—a victim of the traditional marriage system.

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**Story 2: Master Saheb**

- **The Incident:** Pandit Chunchun Jha receives a gift of mangoes from a Mahant. While eating them, a red wasp (*Bidhi*) stings his palm.

- **Village Remedies:** The villagers suggest various cures, including lime, turmeric, and mantras.
- **The English Letter:** Believing that English medicine is superior, the Pandit asks "Master Saheb" (the village English expert) to write a letter to a doctor.
- **The Struggle:** Master Saheb, whose English is rusty, struggles for nearly an hour to translate "wasp". He searches through a dictionary and refuses to use a common Hindi term because it would hurt his prestige.
- **The Resolution:** A young student who just passed his Matriculation exam reveals that the word is "Wasp," humiliating the Master Saheb.

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**Story 3: College-ak Vidyarthi**

- **The Setting:** October 1945, Baidyanathdham station waiting room.
- **The Debate:** Two students, Ramakant (MA in English) and Harikant (Science student), argue about the merits of their departments and the odd behaviors of their professors.
- **The Crisis:** Ramakant goes to the bathroom, which has no water. He accidentally knocks over a full commode and gets covered in filth.
- **The Embarrassment:** He is trapped because his in-laws are arriving at the station to meet him. Harikant and the narrator must secretly find him new clothes.
- **The Irony:** Ramakant, who was previously mocking "unpolished" people, is humiliated when a young girl (his sister-in-law) grabs his bundle of soiled clothes, thinking it is a gift, and realizes what it is.

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**Story 4: Kumramak Bhoj**

- **The Feast:** Pandit Nishanath organizes a massive communal feast (*Bhoj*) for his son's sacred thread ceremony.
- **Social Friction:** The story highlights the pride and petty arguments of the village elders (like Phucho Misar and Jyotishi Kaka) over seating, timing, and traditions.
- **The Menu:** The text describes the traditional Maithili meal, including various vegetable curries, rice, pulses, curd, and meat.
- **The Overeating:** After the meal, a special sweet milk dish (*Sakarauri*) is served. Jyotishi Kaka drinks so much that he chokes and collapses.

- **False Alarm:** The village panics, thinking he is dying, and his family begins mourning. However, he eventually wakes up and immediately asks for his lost glass, showing his persistent focus on material concerns.

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**Story 5: Savinay Nivedan**

- **Orthodoxy:** A strict Pandit wakes his students at dawn for rigorous Sanskrit studies.
- **The Social Conflict:** A student, Ugranand, is threatened with social excommunication because he drank water touched by a washerman to support Mahatma Gandhi's anti-untouchability movement.
- **Hypocrisy:** The Pandit demands a donation of gold as penance. Ugranand rebukes the Pandit and the elders, pointing out that wealthy "upper caste" people regularly associate with Muslims and Christians but are never punished. He leaves, refusing to perform the penance.

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**Story 6: Aatithya-Satkar**

- **Superficial Hospitality:** Professor Ashutosh Babu is famous for his hospitality, but it is often a show to maintain his reputation.
- **The Incident:** A guest and his nephew arrive. The Professor offers food in a way that suggests he expects them to refuse. When they accept, he is forced to scramble to get snacks.
- **Comedy of Errors:** The narrator assists in the "hospitality," leading to a chaotic meal where the guest's nephew chokes on a snack, and the Professor's internal frustration grows as his façade is tested.

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**Story 7: Dhamdaha**

- **The Journey:** A first-person account of a difficult bus journey from Purnia to Dhamdaha in winter.
- **The Ordeal:** The bus is severely overcrowded, breaks down, and is delayed by passengers forgetting items or making stops.
- **The Arrival:** The narrator arrives at the Dak Bungalow at midnight to find no food, no light, and a room infested with bedbugs. He spends a sleepless night in the cold, ending with a poetic encounter at dawn.

## CRTITICISM

The book **"Sasarphani"** (1947) by Nagendra Kumar is a foundational work of modern Maithili fiction that reflects the tension between traditionalism and modernity. Below is a literary criticism of the work through the lenses of Indian and Western theories, the Videha Parallel History Framework, and Navya Nyāya epistemology.

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### 1. Indian & Western Criticism Theories

A criticism of "Sasarphani" reveals a blend of classical Indian aesthetics and Western realism.

- **Rasa Theory (Indian):** The collection primarily evokes **Karuna Rasa** (the pathetic/compassionate sentiment). In the titular story "Sasarphani," the transformation of Jyotsna from a vibrant girl into a "skeleton covered in thin skin" serves as the *vibhava* (stimulus) that creates a deep sense of pathos in the reader regarding the "Kulin" marriage system.
- **Western Realism & Naturalism:** The author explicitly states that the plots are based on "real events" (*vastavik ghatna*). This aligns with Western Realism, where the narrative serves as a mirror to social decay. The detailed description of the filth in the Baidyanathdham waiting room in "College-ak Vidyarthi" leans toward **Naturalism**, exposing the gritty, unpolished reality of human existence.

### 2. Videha Parallel History Framework

The Videha (Mithila) Parallel History Framework examines Maithili literature as a site of "Nav-Jagaran" (Renaissance) that runs parallel to, yet distinct from, the broader Indian national movement.

- **Social Critique as Renaissance:** Nagendra Kumar identifies his work as part of a "new awakening" (*Nav-Jagaran*). The framework highlights how Maithili authors used the short story to critique internal social hierarchies—such as the *Srotriya* and *Jaibar* hierarchies mentioned in "Sasarphani" —rather than focusing solely on colonial resistance.
- **Linguistic Identity:** By dedicating the work to a "lifelong servant of Maithili" , the author asserts a specific regional historiography that prioritizes the preservation of the Maithili language and its unique social struggles.

### 3. Navya Nyāya Epistemology (Gaṅgeśa’s Technique)

Navya Nyāya (the "New Logic") originated in Mithila with Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya. It emphasizes precision in definition (*lakṣaṇa*) and the investigation of knowledge sources (*pramāṇa*).

- **Investigation of Perception (Pratyakṣa):** In stories like "Master Saheb," the narrative functions like a Navya Nyāya inquiry into the nature of "prestige" versus "utility." The "Master" suffers because his perception of his own status is based on a false *anyathākhyāti* (misapprehension)—the belief that his English knowledge must remain opaque to be valid.
- **Syllogistic Structure in Dialogue:** The debates between Sadanand and Harihar's father in "Sasarphani" utilize the logic of Navya Nyāya. Sadanand challenges the definition of "Kulin" (nobility), arguing that the *lakṣaṇa* (characteristic) of nobility should be conduct and education (*vidya*) rather than lineage alone.
- **Precision and Classification:** The author uses a "Nyāya-like" precision to classify the various types of people in the waiting room or the specific types of food at the feast, treating them as distinct *padārthas* (categories) of a decaying social order.

**4. Synthesis of Criticism**

The work functions as a **Sasarphani** (a trap or a noose). The "trap" is the rigid tradition of Mithila, which entangles both the uneducated and the "College Students" who, despite their Western education, remain trapped by social expectations or physical helplessness.

The author’s use of the Sanskrit quote *"Hitaṃ manohāri ca durlabhaṃ vacaḥ"* (Words that are both beneficial and pleasing are rare) serves as the ultimate Navya Nyāya *siddhānta* (conclusion): the book aims to provide a "truthful" logic that may be bitter to the traditionalists but is necessary for social reform.

## *Formal Analysis*

Sasarphānī's stories belong to the social-realist tradition of mid-20th-century Maithili prose that also includes the early work of Braj Kishore Varma and Radhakrishna Baher. The title metaphor — the slender snake navigating the paddy fields — is an example of vakrokti at the level of the title itself: it prepares the reader for a sinuous, indirect, unpredictable narrative movement. Stories in this collection navigate village social hierarchies with the light irony

and deep pathos that characterise the best of post-Harimohan Jha Maithili fiction.

Applying dhvani theory: the persistent undercurrent in Nagendra Kumar's stories is the sthāyibhāva of karuṇa (compassion/pathos) arising from the vulnerability of women, the poor, and the socially marginalised within the Mithilā village complex. Individual stories trace the micro-politics of family life, the injustices of arranged marriage, the humiliations of poverty, and occasional moments of grace. The snake metaphor of the title operates at the level of dhvani throughout: lives are slender, sinuous, in constant danger of being crushed.

The 87 pages of the volume contain what internal evidence suggests are eight to ten stories of varying length. The publication in Muzaffarpur (rather than Patna or Delhi) signals a regional, grassroots circulation network. The Himalaya Press, Patna, as printer, and the literary publisher Sahitya Karyalay as distributor, together suggest the mid-20th-century network of small Maithili publishers who constituted the backbone of the Parallel Tradition before the internet era.

### *Nagendra Kumar's Civil Service Voice*

The tension between Nagendra Kumar's official identity (Bihar Civil Service) and his literary identity (Maithili story-writer) generates a productive creative friction. His stories are marked by an insider's knowledge of how the administrative state impinges on village life — the collector's visit, the census, the requisitioning of land — and by an outsider's empathy for those the state apparatus bypasses or crushes. This dual perspective aligns with what Homi Bhabha calls the 'hybrid' subject: inhabiting two discourse-worlds, belonging fully to neither, writing from the interstice.

In Navya Nyāya terms, his critical position as narrator involves pratyakṣa (direct perception from civil service experience) and anumāna (inference from systemic patterns): both pramāṇas are active in constructing his social world. His stories demonstrate that valid knowledge of rural Mithila requires both direct observation and reasoned inference from structural regularities — a combination Gaṅgeśa would recognise as epistemically complete.

### *Critical Assessment*

Sasarphānī (1940) is an early and significant contribution to Maithili social-realist fiction predating the post-Independence institutionalisation of the Sahitya Akademi. Its obscurity — it was never reprinted or translated —

illustrates precisely the archival failure that the Videha Parallel History seeks to address. Applying postcolonial theory: the work is doubly marginalised, as Maithili (against Hindi hegemony) and as pre-Akademi (outside the institutional distribution network). Its recovery is an act of literary justice.

## 3.3 Gopalji Jha 'Gopesh' — Gumm Bhelaṭhāṛh Chhī

***Bibliographic Details***

Title: Gumm Bhelaṭhāṛh Chhī (गुम्म भेल ठाढ़ छी — 'Suddenly / Silently it Stood / Fell Silent'). Author: Shri Gopalji Jha 'Gopesh'. Publisher: Thudha Parivar, Pahil Lap, Kazipura, Patna-4. Printer: Adarsh Press, Patna-4. Pages: 32. Price: ₹1. Foreword by: Prof. Harismohan Bhaji (Bhadra-nāyak vidyā-nirdeshak Manaṅt). The volume carries a short introductory poem ('Āhemāhe') in which Gopesh reflects on the difficulty of making fresh claims for Maithili poetry in an era when the 'old' has calcified into canonical 'puranā' (the old) — and the challenge is to find a new 'mab' (mine/new).

The title is a condensed and arresting piece of vakrokti: gumm (suddenly silent, unexpectedly so) bhelaṭhāṛh (became standing, became erect or upright) chhī (is/has). The phrase is grammatically ambiguous — who or what became suddenly silent? — and this ambiguity is sustained across the work.

**GOPALJI JHA GOPESH**

Maithili poetry collection titled "Gumm Bhel Thadh Chhi" (I Stand Still/Stunned)

by Gopalji Jha 'Gopesh'

It was published in 1966 (Shaka 1888)

by the "Parivar" publishing house in Patna.

Below is a complete translation and summary of the introductory materials, the table of contents, and several key poems included in the text.

Front Matter and Introduction

Publication Details

Author: Gopalji Jha 'Gopesh'.

Publisher: Parivar, Kazipur, Patna-4.

Printer: Adarsh Press .

Price: One Rupee (Ek Taka).

Dedication: Dedicated to Shri Aniruddha Jha, M.A., Department of Philosophy, Patna University.

Author’s Preface (Ahemahe)

The author reflects on the nature of originality and time:

He claims no absolute originality in feeling or expression.

He defines "old" as that which is buried under the feet of time, and "new" as that which blows against the prevailing winds.

He mentions his first collection, Sonadaik Chitthhi, and notes that while it received mixed reviews, its popularity encouraged this second collection.

He credits Professor Hari Mohan Jha as his guide and acknowledges his wife, Shrimati Ramavati Jha, for her suggestions on word choice.

Table of Contents (Selected)

The collection contains poems reflecting on Mithila, modernity, and the war era (specifically the 1962 and 1965 conflicts):

| No. | Poem Title | Page |

| : | : | : |

| 1 | Mithilak Pratinidhi (Representative of Mithila) | 1 |

| 4 | Hummer Eah Yug (This Era of Mine) | 5 |

| 5 | Ek Vyaktittva: Dui Chitra (One Personality: Two Pictures) | 6 |

| 6 | Freelancer | 10 |

| 8 | Yug Dharma (Duty of the Age) | 12 |

| 12 | He Kavi Kokil (O Poet-Cuckoo) | 14 |

| 14 | Yatharth (Reality) | 20 |

| 15 | Kalpana (Imagination) | 21 |

| 18 | Sonadaik Nav Chitthhi (Sonadai's New Letter) | 24 |

| 23 | Jai Jawan Jai Kisan (Hail the Soldier, Hail the Farmer) | 40 |

| 24 | Yugbodh (Consciousness of the Age) | 41 |

| 25 | Barah Varshak Baad Sasurak Yatra (In-laws' Visit After 12 Years) | 46 |

| 26 | Gumm Bhel Thadh Chhi (I Stand Still/Stunned) | 48 |

**Key Poem Translations**

1. Representative of Mithila (Mithilak Pratinidhi)

The author expresses pride in his identity:

"I am the representative of that land where the soil and water are not separate, where the barren lands laugh, and the eyes find peace in the vast fields... where the Kamala river flows and Annapurna fills every home's granary."

He describes Mithila as a place of deep culture, where festivals like Chaurchan are celebrated, where "Satyam Shivam Sundaram" is a lived reality, and where scholars like Vachaspati and Mandan Misra once walked.

2. O Poet-Cuckoo (He Kavi Kokil)

This satirical poem addresses the legendary Maithili poet Vidyapati (Kavi Kokil), imagining him in the modern 1960s.

As a Lyricist: He would wear nylon shirts and Bata slippers, go to Bombay, and write spicy film songs for Lata Mangeshkar.

As a Professional: He might be an IAS officer, a corrupt contractor, a doctor charging high fees, or a politician constantly traveling between Patna and Delhi.

3. Sonadai's New Letter (Sonadaik Nav Chitthhi)

Written during the Chinese aggression, this poem takes the form of a letter from "Sonadai" (a female persona):

She writes from a rifle training center, stating she practices parade and rifle shooting daily.

She vows not to let the "Chinese foot" advance and mocks the "deception" of the "Hindi-Chini Bhai-Bhai" slogan.

She describes donating her jewelry (bangles and rings) for the national defense fund.

4. Hail the Soldier, Hail the Farmer (Jai Jawan Jai Kisan)

A tribute to Lal Bahadur Shastri:

It praises the achievements of "Tashkent" and Shastri's role as a peace messenger.

It describes him as a "Brave Human" (Bahadur Manav) whose name will be written in golden letters in history for protecting democracy.

5. I Stand Still (Gumm Bhel Thadh Chhi)

The title poem uses a recurring motif of the author standing at various locations (crossroads, Mahendru Ghat, Lohna Road station) "picking tobacco" while watching the theater of life:

He observes the shift from traditional attire (Mirjai) to modern "Drainpipe" trousers and transistors.

He notes the loss of traditional values—where grandmothers used to teach "Saate au Bhavat" (traditional lore), they now teach "One-Two" to their grandchildren.

CRITICISM

This literary criticism analyzes Gopalji Jha 'Gopesh's' **"Gumm Bhel Thadh Chhi"** (1966) through a synthesis of classical Indian aesthetics, Western modernist theory, the Videha Parallel History Framework, and Navya-Nyāya epistemology.

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**1. Navya-Nyāya Epistemology & Gaṅgeśa's Technique**

In the preface, Gopesh notes that truth on the "rock of history" is constantly being eroded. This mirrors the **Navya-Nyāya** concern with *pramāṇa* (valid means of knowledge).

- **Avacchedakatā (Limitation/Precision):** Gopesh employs a proto-Navya-Nyāya technique by defining the "New" (*Nav*) and "Old" (*Puran*) through precise qualifiers (*avacchedaka*). He defines "Old" as that which is suppressed by the feet of time, and "New" as that which resists the prevailing winds.
- **Anuvyavasāya (Apperception):** The recurring motif in the title poem—standing at a crossroads (*chowbatti*) while "picking tobacco"—is a state of *anuvyavasāya*. The poet is not just observing; he is observing himself observing.
- **Gangesha's Influence:** The poet explicitly references **Gangesha** (the founder of Navya-Nyāya) as an "avatar" whose light of logic still shines in Mithila. This suggests the collection isn't just emotional, but a logical inquiry into the "existence of man" (*Manukkshak Astitva*).

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**2. The Videha Parallel History Framework**

This framework posits Mithila (Videha) as a space where ancient metaphysical depth and modern material chaos exist in parallel.

- **Dialectical Continuity:** Gopesh represents the **Mithila of the past** (Vachaspati, Mandan Misra, and the Kamala river) alongside the **Mithila of the present** (transistors, nylon shirts, and "drainpipe" trousers).
- **The Representative Identity:** In "Mithilak Pratinidhi," he claims to represent a land where "Satyam Shivam Sundaram" is the bedrock. However, this history is "parallel" rather than linear; the poet stands at a "junction of eras" (*Yugsandhi*) where the "ancient tradition" has been "thrown into the furnace".

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**3. Western Criticism: Modernism and Satire**

Gopesh's work aligns with mid-20th-century **Western Modernism**, specifically the "Stream of Consciousness" and the "Alienated Observer."

- **The Prufrockian Observer:** Like T.S. Eliot's Prufrock, the persona in "Gumm Bhel Thadh Chhi" is paralyzed by observation. He stands "stunned" (*Gumm*) at railway stations and ghats.
- **Satire and the Burlesque:** In "He Kavi Kokil," Gopesh uses a Western satirical lens to deconstruct the "Poet-Cuckoo" (Vidyapati). He imagines the

medieval saint-poet as a modern "Freelancer" or a corrupt IAS officer. This serves as a **Post-Colonial** critique of how traditional icons are commodified in the "Sputnik era".

- **Existentialism:** The poem "Manukkshak Astitva" views man as a "sacrificial goat" whose achievements are merely "suppressed desires". This echoes Satrean existentialist angst.

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**4. Indian Aesthetic Theory (Rasa and Dhvani)**

While the work is modernist, it remains rooted in **Dhvani** (suggestion) and **Vibhatsa/Hasya Rasa**.

- **Hasya (The Comic):** The "One Personality: Two Pictures" poem creates *Hasya Rasa* by juxtaposing a wealthy trader (*Pokodimal*) with his Alshasian dog and a "Scotland girl" against the backdrop of a "magnificent hotel".
- **Vibhatsa (The Loathsome):** In "Yatharth" (Reality), the description of an old woman trying to look young—painted cheeks, fake teeth, and powdered face—evokes a sense of *Vibhatsa*, representing the decaying state of modern culture.
- **Vira Rasa (The Heroic):** The poems written during the 1962/1965 wars (like "Sonadaik Nav Chitthhi") invoke a traditional *Vira Rasa*, grounding national defense in the "Milk of the Mother" and the "Laxman Rekha".

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**Conclusion**

Gopesh’s collection is a **logical-aesthetic hybrid**. It uses the **Navya-Nyāya** demand for precision to dissect the "Slightness of Life" (*Laghukatha*) while utilizing the **Videha Framework** to show that while the "tunes have changed," the "pan-filled mouth" of the old era remains. The work is a "consciousness of the age" (*Yugbodh*) that finds the poet "still standing," caught between a glorious history and a fragmented, mechanical present.

How do you feel this integration of classical logic and modern angst compares to other poets of the "Prayogvadi" (Experimentalist) movement in Indian literature?

### *Formal Analysis: Drama, Poetry, and the Condensed Form*

Gopesh's volume is generically hybrid: part verse-play, part lyric sequence, part dramatic monologue. This generic indeterminacy is itself a form of vakrokti — the work refuses easy classification, demanding the reader approach it with the polysemous attention reserved for major poetic texts. The introductory poem 'Āhemāhe' (a compound suggesting both 'oh and oh!' and 'astonishment') deploys a rapid sequence of images — the village street, the old well, the crow, the mango grove — that collectively enact a poetics of presence-in-absence: what has 'fallen silent' is the village world, the traditional life, the old song.

The formal structure of the verse is marked by anaphora and parallelism, echoing the classical Maithili gīt tradition while importing a self-conscious modern irony. Each stanza ends with a pivot — a turn that recontextualises the preceding images, producing what Brooks called 'paradox' as the defining property of poetic language. The rasa is complex: the surface tone is śṛṅgāra of the vipralambha type (separation, longing) but the object of longing is not a human beloved but an entire cultural world. This expansion of the love-rasa into an elegy for culture is a signature of modern Maithili poetry.

In Navya Nyāya terms, the poem operates through upamāna (comparison): the silent village is compared to a lover who has gone speechless; the cultural silence is compared to a physical body that has 'stood upright' in shock. These comparisons are not merely decorative: they constitute the poem's cognitive architecture, its way of constructing a valid representation of cultural loss.

### *Theatrical Dimension and the Parallel Stage*

The Videha Parallel History identifies Bechan Thakur as the pre-eminent figure of the 'parallel Maithili stage' — a counter-hegemonic theatrical tradition that challenges the caste-hierarchy-reinforcing comedies of the mainstream Maithili theatre. Gopesh, working in a different register (lyric-drama rather than social satire), participates in this same impulse: his work creates a stage within the text, inviting a reading that is simultaneously literary and theatrical. The Prof. Harismohan Bhaji foreword positions the work within the institutional literary world (Patna University), but the modest production values and small publisher ensure it circulates outside institutional control.

### *Critical Assessment*

Gumm Bhelaṭhāṛh Chhī is a slim but formally dense work. Its recovery is itself a modest institutional recognition that the Parallel History Framework contextualises more fully. The work's refusal of genre clarity, its deployment of

classical aesthetic devices in the service of modern cultural critique, and its embodiment of what the Parallel History calls the 'democratic poetic' make it a significant, if under-studied, text in contemporary Maithili literary history.

## 3.4 Vijaynath Jha — Ahīṅk Lel and Kāmāyanī Chandānuvāda

### *3.4.1 Bibliographic Details: Ahīṅk Lel*

Title: Ahīṅk Lel (अहींक लेल — 'For You [Yours]'). Subtitle: Geet-Ghazal Sangraha (Song and Ghazal Collection). Author: Vijaynath Jha. Father: Pt. Ratnanath Jha (formerly Head, Dept. of Eastern Philosophy, Banaras Hindu University, Varanasi). Address: 3MF 3/42, Bahadurpur Housing Colony, Bhutnath Road, Patna-26. Cover design: Abhay Kr. Jha (contact: 09304429215). Publication: Sabkuchain Printers, Patna. Earlier works listed on the back: (i) Maithili short story collection ('Prākṛtik āpada viṣayak Maithilī gīt'); (ii) Sajnā Jha (another Maithili poetry anthology); (iii) Prākṛtik Āpada Vishayak Maithilī Gīt (Prakashan); (iv) Jāg Bodh — ādivāsī vishayak Hindī Gīt (Prakashan).

The title Ahīṅk Lel is addressed in the second-person plural of Maithili — 'for you-all', 'for yours' — suggesting the collection is offered as a gift to the Maithili-speaking community itself. This dedicatory posture is characteristic of the Parallel Tradition's ethos: the work exists in service of the language and its speakers, not in pursuit of institutional prestige.

**VIJAYNATH JHA**

**A.**

"Ahink Lel" (For You), is a collection of Maithili poetry consisting of songs and ghazals written by Vijay Nath Jha and published in November 2008. The collection is divided into two primary sections: the Git Prabhag (Song Section) and the Ghazal Prabhag (Ghazal Section), covering themes of devotion, nature, and the human condition.

A science graduate from Banaras Hindu University, professional journalist for Aryavarta, and contributor to All India Radio Patna.

Dedication: Dedicated to his father, Pt. Ratinath Jha, in whose "affectionate shadow" the author received his first lessons.

Preface (Prākkathan) by Markandey Pravasi

Classical Integrity: The poet adheres to "rhythmic consciousness" (chandik chetna) and traditional poetic virtues like rasa (emotion), alankar (ornamentation), and pad-lalitya (graceful phrasing).

Heritage: The poetry is rooted in "swadeshi culture" and stands against "foreign impressions" that lack historical and geographical roots.

The Maithili Ghazal: The author argues that the "inventor" of the ghazal's signature style (takhallus) was actually the 14th-century Maithili poet Vidyapati.

"Two Words" (Dū Śabd) by Chhatranand Singh Jha

Emotional Depth: Jha is described as a "sentimental and imaginative poet" whose philosophical outlook serves as a foundation for his work.

Nature: In these poems, nature is not inert matter but "conscious" (sachetan), providing the poet with a fresh perspective.

III. Author's Prologue (Purovāk)

The author explains that he provides a prologue to ensure readers can assimilate the "content, craft, and message" without confusion.

The Title: The title "Ahink Lel" (For You) is derived from the spiritual sentiment: "Thy thing, O Lord, I surrender to Thee".

Poetic Philosophy: Jha believes poetry is born from sensitivity toward the long cycle of joy and sorrow in life. He acknowledges that while he prefers traditional meters, he has included "free verse" (chandmukt) to show he is not restricted to any one "ism".

IV.Sample Translation

"Ahink Lel" (For You) - The Title Ghazal

The progress and motion of life,

The bright world of words,

Fragrance and sacred vows,

For the sake of meaningful essence.

Every moment, heart and mind are enlightened,

I am for you, eternally like one without sorrow.

Desires are not unbridled here,

Agitations are quieted by speech,

What conflict or doubt remains?

This pair is beautiful upon the earth.

The body is drenched, the mind rains like a cloud.

I am for you, eternally like one without sorrow.

"Kavita" (Poetry)

Poetry! It is the high peak, it is the sea floor,

It is the synonym for the great rivers.

It is Kalidasa's Shakuntalam,

It is the leaf of Tulsi in the Manas.

Poetry! If digested, it is simple,

If not, it is the deep poison of Lord Shiva.

Even the venomous snake of the sandalwood forest—
Do not disturb it casually.
Even the God of Love was turned to ash
For harboring the illusion of casting a spell upon poetry's first priest.

Poetry! It is the natural story of life,
It is the sweet voice of the gods.
Companion to the child and the elder,
It is the nectar-queen of the perfected seeker.

"Hamara Puja, Hamara Parichay" (My Worship, My Identity)
You are my worship, my identity, my adornment!
You are the total fortune, the mind, the body, and the flow of blood!!

Subject of lust is dark, the fall brings great joy!
The night is the king of nectar; you are the essence of pleasure!!

There is no desire or affection without purpose or cause!
Make your home in this courtyard; you are my family!!

I admit there was discord, I acknowledge my fault!
Bring more closeness; you are my right!!

'Vijay' has seen and heard much analysis and criticism!
The waters of Narayana flow; you are the stream itself!!

**CRITICISM**

The poetry collection **"Ahīṅk Lel"** by **Vijaynath Jha** presents a sophisticated interplay between classical Maithili tradition and modern existential inquiry. Applying a multi-layered critical framework reveals a work that is both a revival of ancient aesthetics and a response to contemporary history.

### 1. Classical Indian & Western Literary Theory

The collection functions primarily through the lens of **Rasa Theory**. Markandey Pravasi notes that Jha is a poet of **Rasa**, **Alankāra**, and **Chanda**.

- **Rasa (Aesthetic Emotion):** The primary Rasa is **Śānta** (peace/spiritual) , frequently shifting into **Śṛṅgāra** (erotic/romantic) in the Ghazal section.
- **Vidhā (Genre Analysis):** From a Western perspective, the work is **Lyric Poetry**. However, Jha challenges the Western categorizations of "Traditional" vs. "Modern" by including **Chhandmukt** (free verse) alongside strict meters.
- **Dhvani (Suggestion):** In poems like "Kavita," Jha uses poetry as a metaphor for divine poison (*garal*) and nectar (*amrut*), suggesting that true literature is a dangerous yet transformative spiritual act.

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### 2. Navya-Nyāyā Epistemology & Gaṅgeśa's Technique

Vijaynath Jha was the son of Pt. Ratinath Jha, a scholar of Oriental Philosophy. This lineage manifests in his use of **Navya-Nyāyā** techniques—a school of logic founded by **Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya** in Mithila.

- **Avacchedakatā (Limiters):** Jha often defines his subjects by what they are *not* In "Kavita," he defines poetry through the limiter of **नैसर्गिक कहानी** (natural story), distinguishing it from mere intellectual labor.
- **Pratyakṣa (Perception):** The poetry emphasizes that truth is not just theoretical but perceived through the "mind's eye". He speaks of **शब्द-विन्यास** (word-arrangement) as a logical structure that leads to **Bodh** (understanding).
- **Śabda-Pramāṇa (Verbal Testimony):** Jha views the "Word" (*Śabda*) as the ultimate authority. He writes, "The world is alive through words; liberation is through words". This mirrors the Nyāyā belief that valid knowledge can be transmitted through the linguistic testimony of a reliable person (*Āpta*).

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### 3. The Videha Parallel History Framework

The **Videha Parallel History** framework views Mithila (Videha) not just as a geographical location, but as a continuous intellectual landscape that runs parallel to "Mainstream" Indian history.

- **Vidyapati as the Anchor:** Jha (and Pravasi in the preface) argues that the **Maithili Ghazal** is not a foreign import but a parallel evolution of the **Bhanita** style used by **Vidyapati** in the 14th century.

- **Modernity vs. Tradition:** Jha attacks "foreign philosophies" (*vaideśik darśan*) that ignore local history. He positions himself as a "tradition-relative modern poet".
- **Geographical Identity:** The recurring imagery of the **Kosi River** and the floods of Bihar serves as a physical grounding for the Videha experience—the struggle for **Jijiviṣā** (the will to live) amidst natural destruction.

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**4. Synthesis of Critiques**

| Theory | Application in "Ahīṅk Lel" |
|---|---|
| **Western** | Use of the **Ghazal** form and **Free Verse** to explore the "I" (Self). |
| **Navya-Nyāyā** | Precise linguistic definitions of poetry and divinity (*Kavyam Rasatmakam Vakyam*). |
| **Videha History** | Reclaiming the Ghazal as a Maithili innovation and rejecting non-native literary "isms". |
| **Indian Theory** | Integration of **Bhakti** (devotion) and **Śṛṅgāra** (eros) as two sides of the same coin. |

**Conclusion:** Jha’s work is a "Saratsvat" (Saraswati-blessed) and "Swabhimani" (proud) reclamation of Maithili identity. He uses logic to defend emotion, and tradition to anchor modernity.

**B.**

MAITHILI KAMAYINI

Maithili verse translation of the epic Hindi poem "Kamayani," originally written by Jaishankar Prasad. The translation was performed by Vijaynath Jha and published in 2020.

Below is a complete translation and summary of the document's core components, including the preface, the philosophical introduction, and the narrative progression of the poem.

1. Prefatory Materials

Dr. Satyendra Suman praises Vijaynath Jha as a prominent figure in Maithili and Hindi literature.

He notes that translating "Kamayani" is a complex task due to its deep philosophical roots in Shaiva and Buddhist thought.

Author’s Note (Apan Udgar): The translator expresses his goal to preserve the original literary beauty of the Hindi epic while adapting it into the "melodious tones" of Maithili.

He mentions that the Sahitya Akademi originally proposed this task to Markandeya Pravasi, who declined, leading Jha to take up the project.

Introduction (Aamukh): This section traces the history of Manu, the first man, from Vedic literature and the Shatapatha Brahmana

It frames the story not just as a legend but as a "psychological history of humanity".

2. Narrative Summary of the Cantos (Sargas)

The epic is structured into 15 cantos, each representing a state of human consciousness.

Canto 1: Worry (Chinta)

After a catastrophic global flood (Jal-plavan), Manu sits alone on a peak of the Himalayas. He watches the receding waters and is consumed by anxiety about the destruction of the divine race, whose arrogance and obsession with luxury led to their downfall.

Canto 2: Hope (Aasha)

As dawn breaks over the snowy peaks, Manu begins to feel a spark of life. He performs a fire sacrifice (Agnihotra) and leaves a portion of food aside, hoping another survivor might find it.

Canto 3: Faith (Shraddha)

A beautiful woman named Shraddha (also called Kamayani) finds Manu . She encourages him to abandon his ascetic isolation and embrace his role in creating a new humanity . She offers herself as his companion and partner in the "sacrifice of life".

### Canto 4 & 5: Desire (Kaam) and Passion (Vasana)

Manu and Shraddha begin their life together. Manu initially struggles with his internal desires and the memory of the gods' hedonism. However, through Shraddha's presence, he experiences the awakening of love and the physical beauty of the world.

### Canto 6: Shyness (Lajja)

This canto personifies shyness as a protective guide for Shraddha. It describes the internal shift from pure independence to the "surrender" inherent in love and domesticity.

### Canto 7 & 8: Action (Karma) and Jealousy (Irshya)

Manu grows restless and returns to violent habits, like hunting and animal sacrifice, which Shraddha opposes. When Shraddha becomes pregnant and focuses her attention on her unborn child, Manu feels neglected and develops a deep sense of jealousy and possessiveness.

### Canto 9: Intellect (Ida)

Manu abandons Shraddha and wanders until he reaches the ruins of a city ruled by Ida, who represents pure intellect and logic. Under Ida’s guidance, Manu builds a highly advanced, materialistic civilization based on science and industry.

### Canto 10: Dream (Swapna)

Back in the mountains, Shraddha has a prophetic dream about Manu’s struggles in the city. The narrative shifts between her longing for him and Manu's growing ambition and eventual conflict with the citizens he rules.

3. Key Themes and Philosophical Framework

Man and Woman: Manu represents the restless, logical mind, while Shraddha represents the heart, faith, and emotional stability.

Human Development: The epic tracks the evolution of society from primitive survival (Hope) to agricultural stability (Faith) to industrial civilization (Intellect).

The Resolution: The text suggests that peace is only found when intellect (Ida) is balanced by faith (Shraddha), leading to the final state of Ananda (Bliss).

### *3.4.2 Formal Analysis: Geet and Ghazal*

Vijaynath Jha's Ahīṅk Lel brings together two forms: geet (Maithili song-lyric) and ghazal (the Urdu-derived love-lyric form, now widely cultivated in Maithili through the 'Anchinhar Aakhar' movement documented in the Videha Parallel History, Part 4). The ghazal in Maithili inherits the formal requirements of the classical ghazal — the matla (opening couplet in which both lines rhyme), the radif (repeated word or phrase at the end of each sher), the qafia (rhyme scheme), and the maqta (closing couplet in which the poet names himself). Jha's ghazals maintain these conventions while saturating them with Maithili vocabulary, landscape, and affect.

The back-cover blurb (in Maithili) praises the collection as 'tung-śṛṅg samudra tal āchhi / nad-mahānadak padya / Śākuntalem kālidāsas / mānas-tulasī dal āchhi / kavitā' — 'as high as mountaintops, as deep as the ocean, like the metre of great rivers, like the leaf of the manas-tulasī plant: poetry.' This blurb operates as a classical stuti (eulogy) deploying the traditional 'high-low' bipolar simile (mountaintop and ocean floor) to establish the range of the work.

A key thematic preoccupation in Ahīṅk Lel is the passage of time and the persistence of love: āhīṅk (yours) is both a possessive and an address, an acknowledgement that the poetic subject belongs to the beloved and to the community. The ghazals modulate between erotic longing, philosophical reflection, and social commentary. The geets (songs) in the collection are structured for performance, with repeating refrains (ṭek) that invite communal participation — linking the individual lyric to the folk tradition of Maithili performance.

Applying rasa theory: the dominant rasa is śṛṅgāra (in its saṃbhoga, or union, as well as vipralambha, or separation, modes), supported by the śānta rasa in the more philosophically oriented ghazals. Applying Navya Nyāya: the ghazal form itself constitutes a śabda-pramāṇa (verbal testimony) — a tradition of validated poetic speech whose authority is conferred by the genre's long history. Jha's participation in the ghazal tradition is itself an act of epistemic positioning: he claims the right to speak within a validated discourse, while simultaneously inflecting it with Maithili particularity.

Formally, the Maithili Revitalization of Ghazal (documented by the Videha Parallel History as the 'Anchinhar Aakhar' movement) constitutes an act of cultural sovereignty: adapting a Persianate-Urdu form to the Maithili phonological, prosodic, and semantic system. Jha's contribution to this movement places him in a continuum that includes the major Maithili ghazal writers of the post-1990 period.

### *3.4.3 Bibliographic Details: Kāmāyanī Mahākāvya Maithilī Chandānuvāda*

Title: Kāmāyanī (कामायनी) — Mahākāvya: Jaishankar Prasad. Subtitle: Maithilī Chandānuvāda. Translator: Vijaynath Jha. Published: 2020. Publisher: Vikram Prakashan, Krishna Nagar, Delhi (adapted from the Kamayanee originally published by Vikram Prakashan, Delhi). Copyright: Vijaynath Jha. Price: ₹250. Printer: Vishal Print Care, Langer Toli, Patna-4. Typesetting: Shiv Kumar Thakur. Distribution: Vijaynath Jha, 3MF 3/42, Bahadurpur Housing Colony, Bhutnath Road, Patna-26 (Mo. 9308430870); and Shiv Kumar Thakur, Patna (Mo. 9905281145, 9262215128).

The source text — Jaishankar Prasad's Kāmāyanī (1936) — is widely regarded as the greatest Hindi Chhāyāvāda (Romantic-Symbolist) epic poem, in 15 sargas (cantos). Its narrative follows Manu (archetypal Man) and Śraddhā (Faith) through the great Vedic flood and the foundation of a new civilisation, exploring the philosophical tension between intellect (Manu / Prajñā) and intuition (Śraddhā). The work is deeply indebted to Sanskrit Vedic cosmogony, Upanisadic philosophy, and 19th-century European Romanticism (Keats, Shelley, Wordsworth).

### *3.4.4 The Art of Chandānuvāda: Translation as Creation*

Vijaynath Jha's Kāmāyanī translation is not a prose rendering but a chandānuvāda — a verse translation that attempts to match the metrical structure of the original. This is the most demanding mode of literary

translation, requiring the translator to simultaneously manage semantic fidelity, prosodic equivalence, and tonal match. Jha works from Prasad's varṇa-vṛtta metres (classical Sanskrit-derived quantitative metres used in Kāmāyanī) toward Maithili chandas — drawing on the prosodic tradition of Vidyapati and subsequent Maithili court poetry.

The title page confirms the translation is from Vikram Prakashan's edition of Kāmāyanī (the standard Delhi publication): 'Vikram Prakashan: Kṛṣṇa nagar dillī dvārā prakāśit Kāmāyanī se anudita.' This is a crucial attribution — it signals that Jha translates from a specific authoritative text, not from memory or summary. The work thus participates in what Venuti calls 'ethical translation': the translator renders transparent his source, his method, and his intellectual debt.

Dhvani analysis: Prasad's original Kāmāyanī is profoundly dhvani-dependent — its surface narrative of Manu's journey resonates with universal philosophical themes (the conflict of śraddhā and prajñā, faith and reason). Jha's translation must preserve this resonance while activating new harmonics in the Maithili linguistic system. The translator's challenge is to find Maithili words for Prasad's coinages (for example, prajñā as a semi-technical philosophical term) that carry equivalent resonance in the receiving language.

Applying translation theory: Berman's concept of the 'letter' of the original — the specific verbal texture that must be preserved — is tested here. Jha's chandānuvāda is predominantly domesticating: he makes the philosophical epic feel native to Maithili, using local images and prosodic patterns. But key Sanskrit philosophical vocabulary is retained, constituting 'foreignisation' micro-pockets within an otherwise domesticated text. This hybrid strategy reflects the practical demands of serving both the philosophical ambition of the original and the aesthetic expectations of Maithili readers.

The translated text represents an extraordinary feat of sustained creative and scholarly effort. Each of the 15 sargas demands a different metrical register, a different emotional tone, and a different set of philosophical concepts. That Jha completed this project signals a deep engagement with both the Hindi Chhāyāvāda tradition and the classical Maithili prosodic inheritance — placing him squarely within the Parallel History's vision of a Maithili literature that is simultaneously local and universal.

### *3.4.5 Critical Assessment: Vijaynath Jha*

Vijaynath Jha's double achievement — the ghazal-geet collection Ahīṅk Lel and the magisterial Kāmāyanī chandānuvāda — places him among the

significant multi-genre writers of contemporary Maithili literature. His father's academic lineage (Banaras Hindu University, Eastern Philosophy) provides the philosophical depth evident in the Kāmāyanī translation; his journalism and song-writing experience grounds the performative immediacy of the ghazals. Neither work has received academic critical attention commensurate with its ambition.

From the Videha Parallel History's perspective, Jha represents the classic parallel-tradition figure: a writer of genuine literary capacity, working outside institutional channels, producing work that deserves — and requires — critical recovery and dissemination.

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# PART IV: COMPARATIVE AND SYNTHETIC ANALYSIS

## 4.1 Convergences across the Four Authors

Despite their different genres, periods, and registers, the four authors share several significant characteristics. All four write from within the non-institutional, non-Sahitya-Akademi axis of Maithili literary production. All four deploy classical aesthetic forms (rasa, alaṃkāra, chandas) in the service of contemporary social and emotional realities. All four were or are resident in the Patna-Bihar-Mithila heartland, writing for a community of readers who consume literature through informal print networks, radio, and communal performance rather than through academic institutions.

All four works exhibit what the Parallel History calls 'democratic poetics': the use of literary form not to reinforce social hierarchy but to illuminate its costs and contradictions. Ramesh Narayan does this through the laprek's radical compression; Nagendra Kumar through the ironic realism of the civil servant who knows the system from within; Gopesh through the culturally elegiac voice of a community confronting its own silencing; Vijaynath Jha through the philosophical ambition of a translator who brings a major Hindi text home to Maithili.

## 4.2 Divergences and Tensions

The four authors also represent distinct aesthetic and political positions. Where Nagendra Kumar's 1940 stories belong to an earlier generation of Maithili

social realism shaped by nationalist-era humanism, Ramesh Narayan's laprek belongs to the post-liberalisation moment of rapid urbanisation and media saturation. Gopesh's verse drama sits at a historical threshold — the moment of cultural loss — while Vijaynath Jha's translation project looks both backward (to the Sanskrit-Hindi classical tradition) and forward (to a Maithili readership that can access major pan-Indian texts in its own language).

These divergences are not weaknesses but signs of the richness of the Parallel Tradition: it is not a monolithic counter-canon but a multiplicity of voices, registers, and political orientations united by their shared exclusion from the institutional mainstream.

### 4.3 The Navya Nyāya Synthesis

Applied synoptically, Gaṅgeśa's four pramāṇas organise a complete critical account of the four authors' works. Pratyakṣa (direct perception): the close reading of the primary texts provides the sensory foundation of critique — the specific words, images, metres, and structures that constitute the literary facts. Anumāna (inference): from these textual signs, we infer the deeper structures of meaning, the rasa, the dhvani, the sociohistorical significance. Upamāna (comparison): the comparative analysis of the four authors against each other, against the Maithili tradition, and against world literature calibrates the distinctiveness and importance of each. Śabda (verbal testimony): the testimony of the Videha Parallel History, of academic scholarship on Maithili literature, and of the Sanskrit critical tradition contextualises and validates the critical judgements reached through the other three pramāṇas.

The result is a critical account that is both epistemically rigorous (in the Navya Nyāya sense) and aesthetically responsive (in the rasa-dhvani sense): it neither reduces the literary works to sociological symptoms nor treats them as aesthetically autonomous objects divorced from history and politics.

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## APPENDIX: NOTE ON METHODOLOGY AND SOURCES

This research was compiled from the following primary source categories: (i) direct examination of five of the books (provided as primary sources); (ii) the Videha digital archive at www.videha.co.in, including the Pothi (book archive) page and the Parallel History sections; (iii) published academic scholarship on Maithili literature, including the IJCRT (October 2025) survey of Maithili short fiction; (iv) classical Indian philosophical and literary-critical texts; (v) standard Western critical theory texts.

All Maithili titles and proper names have been transliterated using the standard IAST system where precision is required, and simplified romanisation elsewhere for readability.

The Videha Parallel History Framework is an ongoing, living scholarly project. Parts cited in this report were accessed via the Videha website in April 2026. As new parts are published, the contextualisation of the four authors studied here may be further refined.

ADDENDUM

Tr.of Gopalji Jha ‘Gopesh’

Gajendra Thakur

Gopalji Jha ‘Gopesh’

Late Gopalji Jha ‘Gopesh’ (1931-2008) is a Maithili poet of eminence. His published works include “Album,” “Gumm Bhel Tharh Chhi,” “Son Daik Chitthi,” and “Aab Kahu man Kehan Lagaiye.”

Gajendra Thakur

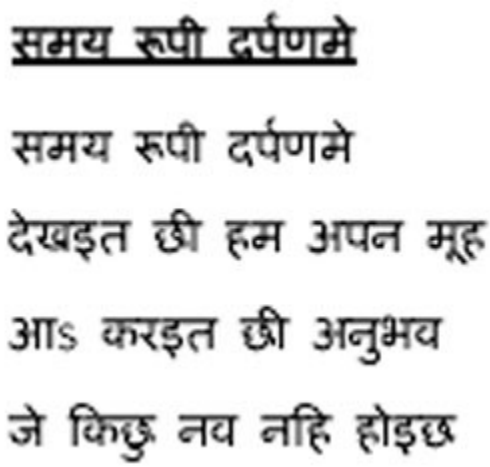
Gajendra Thakur (born 1971) is an Indian author. He writes in the Maithili language, a language spoken in Northern Bihar (of India) and South-Eastern Nepal. He is an author, lexicographer, historian (of Mithil a- ancient Videha and of Maithili); and palaeographer, he has deciphered ancient and medieval palm leaf inscriptions in Tirhuta script of Maithili Language (Mithilakshar script). He has deciphered scripts inscribed on temples/ dilapidated buildings throughout the length and breadth of Mithila.

He has also compiled an English-Maithili Computer Dictionary (Shruti Publication, Delhi 2009 with a preface by Prof. Udaya Narayana Singh). He has helped in preparing Unicode application for Mithilakshar (Tirhuta) script. His Kurukshetram Antarmanak (Shruti Publication, Delhi 2009 with a preface by Prof. Udaya Narayana Singh) in seven volumes and Videha (in 127 volumes) changed the literary scene "in every genre" of Maithili language. His Maithili-English dictionary is only such dictionary available in Maithili

He wrote KuruKshetram Antarmanak in seven volumes Thereafter his transcribed 11000 palm-leaf inscriptions were published in a single volume with an explanatory introduction as "Genome Mapping –450 AD to 2009 AD- Mithilak Panji Prabandh".; later its sequel "Geneological Mapping-450 AD to 2009 AD- Mithilak Panji Prabandh Vol II" was released.

He is editor of Videha- First Maithili Fortnightly e journal.

**LESSON 068 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**


समय रूपी दर्पणमे

समय रूपी दर्पणमे
देखइत छी हम अपन मूह
आऽ करइत छी अनुभव
जे किछु नव नहि होइछ

**Original poem in Maithili. Translated into English by Gajendra Thakur**

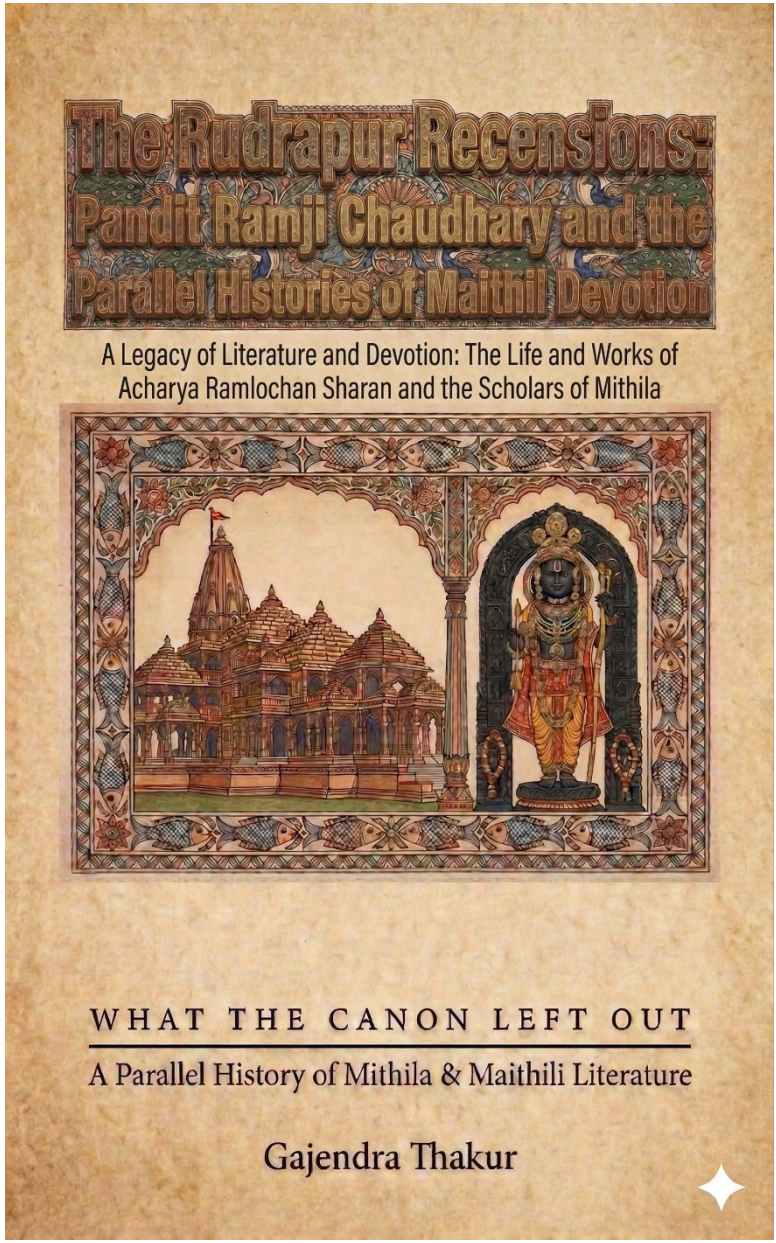
# Looking into the Mirror of Time

Looking into the mirror of time
I see my face
And feel
That nothing new happens
Takes birth
Daily in the early morning
Some desires of this kind
Within the mind upward goes emotion’s wave
That something will happen today
But Sun-God impresses

On the head of day some news of this kind
In which I to myself
Am not able to adjust
Flying distances with dusty wings
Fatty becomes the pet pigeon likewise
My waves of emotions
Become thick find support from my experiences
Prove that
Nothing new happens
Whatever comes in front of us
That happens to be on the stone-piece of time
The same worn-out old thing old ideology
That boasts of being new
And squeezes the pain out of tired-inert mind.

[courtesy https://museindia.com/ Muse India the literary ejournal Nov-Dec 2008 ISSN: 0975-1815]

**LESSON 069 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**




1

# The Rudrapur Recensions: Pandit Ramji Chaudhary and the Parallel Histories of Maithil Devotion/

2

A Legacy of Literature and Devotion: The Life and Works of Acharya Ramlochan Sharan and the Scholars of Mithila

3

**RESEARCH & CRITICAL APPRECIATION**

OF THE WORKS OF

**Pt. Ramji Chaudhary (1878-1952)**

**& Acharya Ramlochan Sharan (1889-1971)**

**1**

**The Rudrapur Recensions: Pandit Ramji Chaudhary and the Parallel Histories of Maithil Devotion**

**Vividh Bhajnavali** (Miscellaneous Hymn Collection), is a collection of devotional poetry and songs written by **Pandit Shri Ramji Chaudhary** from Rudrapur, Darbhanga (now Madhubani). Published in 1947/ **1948** (Sambat 2004), the book contains hymns dedicated to various Hindu deities and philosophical reflections on the nature of life.

Below is the English translation of the key sections and a selection of representative hymns:

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**Front Matter & Introduction**

- **Title:** Miscellaneous Hymn Collection (Vividh Bhajnavali)
- **Edition:** First Edition (1,000 copies)
- **Author:** Pt. Shri Ramji Chaudhary, Village: Rudrapur, Post: Andhratharhi, District: Darbhanga
- **Date:** Falgun Shukla Purnima, Sambat 2004 (approx. March 1948)
- **Price:** Two Annas

**Selected Hymn Translations**

**1. Prayer to Lord Ganesha (Vinay)**

**"Salutations to Shri Ganesha..."**

Victory to Ganesha, the son of Shiva, beautiful, exceedingly kind, and the protector of the humble. You are the long-bellied one (Lambodara) with the face of an elephant; even the thousand-headed serpent cannot fully describe your glory. I am very ignorant and know nothing; please grant me the meditation of your lotus feet in my heart. Ramji pleads to you; I wish to describe the qualities of Rama through my speech.

**2. Hymn to Goddess Bhavani (Durga)**

**"Your feet are my refuge, O Bhavani..."**

O Queen of Avadh, remove the three types of suffering. Why do you sit still without looking at me, seeing the distress of your devotee?. All the gods desire the dust of your feet; please keep this servant in your shelter. Even Shesha, Ganesha, and Indra meditate upon you and chant your name day and night, knowing your greatness. Ramji, knowing he is sinking, has fallen at your feet; take me across the waters of this worldly existence.

**3. Hymn to Lord Shiva (Mahesh Bani)**

**"Serve the mind of Shankara, the exceedingly kind..."**

He is the destroyer of his servant’s sorrows and is merciful. The Ganges flows from his matted hair, his body is smeared with ash, and a garland of skulls hangs from his chest. With a trident in hand and a tiger skin as a garment, he resides in Kailash with Goddess Girija. Ramji, being very humble, asks for your blessing so that he may quickly meet the Lord of Avadh.

**4. Songs of Separation (Holi & Seasonal)**

**"The month of Chait has arrived, O Rama..."**

My beloved has not returned in the month of Chait, and my heart is restless. I find no joy in my home, Cupid torments me, and I cannot sleep. Day and night the cuckoo birds sing in the gardens where flowers bloom, but for Ramji, this beautiful season goes to waste because I haven’t met my beloved.

**5. Philosophical Reflection on Life**

**"O foolish mind, chant the name of Rama..."**

This is the only work that will help you in life. Otherwise, you will fall into the dark well of ignorance, and who will be strong enough to save you then?. Do not be misled by your youth; in a moment, the body can perish. No matter how much you love your family, wife, or children, they will not go with you in the end.

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**Front Matter & Publication Details**

- **Title**: Miscellaneous Hymn Collection (Vividh Bhajnavali)
- **Edition**: First time, 1,000 copies
- **Author**: Pt. Shri Ramji Chaudhary
- **Address**: Village- Rudrapur, Post- Andhratharhi, District Darbhanga
- **Date**: Falgun Shukla Purnima, Sambat 2004
- **Price**: Two Annas
- **Printer**: Shri Birbal Singh, A. Bose Press, Motijheel, Muzaffarpur

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**Hymns of Prayer (Vinay)**

**Hymn 1: To Lord Ganesha**

"Salutations to Lord Ganesha. Victory to Ganesha, the son of Shiva, beautiful, exceedingly kind, and the protector of the humble. You are the long-bellied one with an elephant’s face; even the thousand-headed serpent (Shesha) cannot describe your glory. I am very ignorant; please grant me the meditation of your lotus feet in my heart. Ramji pleads to you; I wish to describe the qualities of Rama."

**Hymn 2: To Goddess Bhavani (Durga)**

"O Goddess, my hope is in your feet. Remove the three types of suffering, O Queen of Avadh. Why do you sit still without looking at me? Seeing the distress of your devotee, my mind is troubled. All the gods desire the dust of your feet; keep this servant in your shelter. Even Shesha, Ganesha, and Indra meditate upon you and chant your name day and night. Knowing I am drowning, I have fallen at your feet; take me across the ocean of existence."

**Hymn 3: To Goddess Durga (Lāyani Style)**

"Listen, O Durga Bhavani, I am presenting my plea. I have searched among all the gods and come to you; what use is it to count on humans?. I am trapped in the world's net and cannot escape. You killed the demon Mahishasura; your limits are unknown. My only hope is in your grace; Ramji desires only the dust of your feet."

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**Hymns to Lord Shiva (Mahesh Bani)**

**Hymn 5: Service to Shankara**

"O mind, serve Shankara, who is exceedingly kind and the destroyer of his servant's sorrows. His matted hair is adorned with the Ganges, his body is smeared with ash, and a garland of skulls hangs from his chest. He drinks the nectar of victory and wanders like one intoxicated. Residing in Kailash with Goddess Girija, he carries a trident and wears a tiger skin. Lord of Kashi, I have run to your door; make me happy as I meet the Lord of Avadh."

**Hymn 53: A Plea to Chandeshwar**

"Listen, O Lord Chandeshwar, look upon me with grace, for I am a helpless orphan. I have wandered and realized that everyone is selfish; friends and kin all have their own motives. I do not know the Vedas or Puranas, nor do I know the ways of worship; I am constantly worried. You are the fulfiller of all desires; O Bhola Nath, fulfill Ramji's wishes."

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**Hymns to Lord Krishna & Rama**

**Hymn 6: To Lord Raghunandan (Rama)**

"Victory to Raghunandan! Even Sharada and Narada cannot find the end of your glory. The Vedas and scriptures tire of describing you. You sit on a throne with Lakshmana and Hanuman, fanned by whisks, with a beauty that exceeds millions of Cupids. My mind is dull; how can I attain your vision?."

**Hymn 7: To Lord Yadunandan (Krishna)**

"Victory to Yadunandan! You took an avatar for the sake of the gods, O lotus-eyed one. In Gokul, you played with cowherd boys, stole butter, and killed demons like Putana and Keshi. Standing by the Kadamba tree, you play the flute, and the sound enchants gods, sages, and serpents alike. Ramji asks: how can I, with such a wicked and dull mind, know your qualities?."

**Hymn 9: To Hanuman**

"Listen to my prayer, O Hanuman! You are the only helper of the humble. You met Rama and Sugriva, ending their sorrow. You crossed the ocean to find Janaki (Sita). When Lakshmana was struck by power, you quickly brought the Sanjivani herb to save his life. Ramji seeks your shelter; knowing me to be miserable and without refuge, protect me."

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**Hymns of Separation (Holi & Seasons)**

**Hymn 23: Playing Holi**

"O Krishna, I will not play Holi with you. You come suddenly and catch me by force, throwing color and rubbing red powder on my face. My age is delicate; my pearl necklace broke as you grabbed my waist. Ramji says: I will tell Yashoda today so she can tie you up."

**Hymn 37: The Four Months of Rain (Chaumasa)**

"My beloved has not come; how can I stay alone in the house?. The month of Asadh has come, and the arrows of separation pierce me; the wind howls and the lightning flashes. In Shravan, the bed feels like fire as the rain falls. My beloved remains in Gokul; I have no hope for life. Ramji asks: when will I meet you?."

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**Philosophical Reflections (Bhajan & Kavitta)**

**Hymn 50: The Morning Prayer**

"O mind, chant the name of Rama in the morning; the drum for the final journey is constantly beating. You are needlessly attached to your wife, children, and kin. At the end, no one will ask about you when your life departs. You spent childhood in play and youth in the charms of women. Now that you are old, you wander for wealth, yet your desires do not fade. Kings and beggars have all left; no one stays forever. Ramji says: if you wish to be saved, take refuge at the feet of the Lord of Raghu."

**Hymn 71: The Vanity of Taste**

"You have eaten butter, sugar, kachori, and sweets like ghevar and rabri. You have tasted peda, jalebi, barfi, and laddu. You have consumed betel nut, cardamom, and coconut. Ramji says: after tasting all these flavors, you will depart empty-handed because you never tasted the essence of Rama’s name."

**Hymn 74: The Final Journey**

"You received this beautiful and rare human body, wealth, a home, and a family. You rode horses and sat in elephant palanquins. But when the warrant of death arrives, you will be carried on a bamboo stretcher by four people to the cremation ground. Ramji says: no one in this world will be of use in the end; you will regret that you did not chant the name of Rama."

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**Publication Credits**

- **Printer:** Shri Birbal Singh
- **Press:** A. Bose Press, Motijheel, Muzaffarpur
- **Closing:** Iti Siddhirastu. Shubhanchastustu (Thus let there be success. Let there be auspiciousness).

CRITICISM

The **Vividh Bhajnavali** by Pt. Ramji Chaudhary represents a profound intersection of Maithil folk devotion and classical Sanskrit scholasticism. This literary criticism analyzes the to uncover its structural and epistemological depth.

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**1. Indian Literary Criticism: Rasa and Bhakti**

From the perspective of classical Indian poetics (*Kavyashastra*), the text is dominated by **Bhakti Rasa** (the aesthetic of devotion).

- **Vatsalya and Shanta Rasa**: The hymns to Ganesha and Shiva evoke a sense of *Shanta* (peace) through surrender. However, the *Mahesh Vanis* (songs of Shiva) often blend this with *Vatsalya* (parental/familial affection), treating Shiva as a domestic figure of the Maithil household.
- **Vipralambha Shringar**: The seasonal songs (*Chaumasa* and *Chait*) utilize the *Viraha* (separation) motif. The "Barahmasa" structure acts as the *Uddipana Vibhava* (stimulating cause), where the arrival of rain or spring intensifies the devotee’s longing for the divine.

**2. Western Literary Criticism: Existentialism and Didacticism**

The text exhibits strong parallels with **Christian Existentialism** and **Memento Mori** traditions.

- **Existential Dread**: Hymns like 50 and 74 function as a critique of the "inauthentic self". The author uses the image of the "final drum" (*kuch nagara*) to highlight the absurdity of material accumulation in the face of inevitable death.
- **The "Other"**: In Western terms, the devotee's relationship with the divine is a "dialogical encounter." The speaker frequently identifies as the "other"-the ignorant (*gamar*), the sinner (*adhama*), or the orphan (*anath*)-to establish a baseline for divine grace.

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**3. The Videha Parallel History Framework**

This framework views the text as a product of the **Mithila (Videha)** intellectual geography, which historically balanced high logic (*Nyaya*) with deep emotionalism (*Padavali*).

- **Cultural Continuity**: Pt. Chaudhary's work is a 20th-century continuation of the tradition started by Vidyapati. It maintains the "Videha Parallel"-the ability to hold a rigorous philosophical worldview (*Siddhanta*) alongside "Laukika" (folk) expressions like *Tirhut* and *Holi* songs.
- **Identity**: The specific mention of Darbhanga and local post offices anchors the "Universal Rama" into a "Local Mithila," a hallmark of the Videha framework where the sacred geography is superimposed onto the village.

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**4. Navya-Nyaya Epistemology and Technique**

Although the text is poetic, the influence of **Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya** (the founder of Navya-Nyaya from Mithila) is visible in the *structure* of the author's arguments.

- **Anuvyavasaya (Reflective Awareness)**: The author utilizes a technique of *Anuvyavasaya*-knowing that one knows. In Hymn 13, the devotee doesn't just suffer; he categorizes his suffering into "threefold pain" (*trividh tap*), mirroring the logical classification found in Nyaya.
- **Definition by Negation (Vyatireka)**: Gaṅgeśa's technique of defining a thing by what it is *not* is reflected in the philosophical *Kavittas*. The author defines "Human Purpose" (*Purushartha*) by negating the value of wealth, family, and physical beauty, stripping away the *Upadhi* (limitations) to reveal the *Paramartha* (ultimate truth).

- **Pratyaksha (Perception) vs. Sabda (Word)**: The author acknowledges the tension between the "unseen" divine and the "visible" world. He resolves this through *Sabda Pramana*-the authority of the Holy Name as a valid means of knowledge (*Pramana*) that bridges the gap between the mundane and the transcendental.

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**Summary Table: Comparative Analysis**

| Theory | Central Concept in Vividh Bhajnavali | Evidence from Text |
|---|---|---|
| **Indian Poetics** | *Prapatti* (Surrender) | "I have fallen at your feet" |
| **Western Theory** | *Vanitas* (Vanity of life) | The listing of luxury items that won't go to the grave |
| **Videha History** | Localized Sacredness | Integration of Shiva into Maithil family life |
| **Navya-Nyaya** | Logical Classification | Categorizing life stages and types of suffering |

2

**A Legacy of Literature and Devotion: The Life and Works of Acharya Ramlochan Sharan and the Scholars of Mithila**

The provided document is the **Jayanti Smarak Granth** (Anniversary Commemorative Volume), published in **1942** to celebrate the **Golden Jubilee** (50th anniversary) of **Shri Ramlochan Sharan Ji**, a renowned literary figure and educator from Bihar.

Due to the extreme length of the 1,000+ page document, the following is a comprehensive translation and summary of its primary sections, including the editorial vision and the historical survey of Mithila's scholars.

**1. Title and Dedication (Pages 1-13)**

- **Title:** Jayanti-Smarak: Shri Ramlochan Sharan Ji's Golden Jubilee.
- **Editors:** Professor Shivpujan Sahay, Professor Harimohan Jha, and Shri Achyutanand.

- **Dedication:** Presented to Rai Sahib Ramlochan Sharan of ‘Pustak Bhandar’ by Maharaja Kameshwar Singh Bahadur of Darbhanga.
- **Tribute:** He is described as a "Pillar of Pride for Bihar," a creator of modern children’s literature, a venerable teacher of Hindi grammar, and the founder of the ‘Pustak Bhandar’ publishing house.

**2. Editorial Statement (Pages 32-41)**

The editors explain that while other Hindi literary giants like Dwivedi Ji and Hariaudh Ji were honored during their lifetimes, Bihar had neglected to similarly honor its own scholars.

- **Objective:** To rectify this by performing a "great literary sacrifice" (Yagya) in the form of this commemorative volume.
- **Subject:** Ramlochan Sharan was chosen unanimously for his 25 years of tireless service to Hindi literature.
- **Scope:** The book was designed to be a "Reference Book" for future generations, illuminating the historical and cultural significance of Bihar which previously lay in darkness.

**3. Historical Survey: Scholars of Mithila (Pages 50-85)**

A major portion of the document, written by Shri Janardan Jha ‘Jansidan’, provides a detailed history of Sanskrit scholarship in Mithila.

**The Ancient Tradition**

- **Centers of Learning:** Mithila was once the world center for Vedas and Vedanta. Students traveled from across India (Anga, Vanga, Kalinga) to study under its masters.
- **The ‘Chaupar’ System:** Education was free. Teachers (Pandits) lived simple lives, often eating only greens (*saag*), and refused to beg from kings.
- **Academic Rigor:** Students first mastered their subjects locally before moving to Kashi (Varanasi) for advanced examinations.

**Notable Historical Figures**

- **Gautama Muni:** Author of the Nyaya Shastra, lived in Brahmpur, Darbhanga.
- **Maharishi Yajnavalkya:** Resided in Kusuma village; his ‘Smriti’ is world-famous.
- **Mandana Misra:** A supreme scholar of Nyaya and Mimamsa who debated Adi Shankaracharya. His wife, Sharda Devi (Ubhaya Bharati), is described as an incarnation of Saraswati.

- **Vachaspati Misra:** An unparalleled scholar of all Shastras. He named his famous commentary ‘Bhamati’ after his childless wife to immortalize her name.
- **Vidyapati Thakur:** The world-famous Maithili poet and scholar under King Shiv Singh.
- **Mahesh Thakur:** A scholar of grammar and logic who was gifted the kingdom of Mithila by Emperor Akbar.

**Contemporary Scholars (Circa 1942)**

- Dr. Ganganath Jha: A famous scholar of both English and Sanskrit, former Vice-Chancellor of Allahabad University.
- **Balakrishna Misra:** Principal of the Sanskrit Department at Kashi Hindu University.
- **Madhusudan Jha:** A Vedic scientist whose knowledge of the Vedas was considered unmatched for centuries.

**4. Commemorative Poems (Pages 46-49)**

- **"At the Door of the Past" by ‘Dinkar’:** A poem calling upon the gods and heroes of Bihar’s history (Magadha, Nalanda, Vaishali) to awaken and bring light to the darkness of the present.
- **"Word Tribute" by ‘Kesari’:** A praise of the Hindi language and the artistic heritage of Bihar, honoring the "word-piercing warrior" Ramlochan Sharan.

**5. Table of Contents Summary (Pages 14-31)**

The book covers a vast range of topics beyond biography, including:

- **Education:** Historical accounts of Nalanda and Vikramshila Universities.
- **Philosophy:** Discussions on Jainism, Buddhism, and the concept of God in various Indian philosophies.
- **Culture:** The music of Bihar, Patna-style painting, and the history of Hindi journalism in the state.
- **Geography/Economy:** Minerals of Bihar, its forest wealth, and cattle rearing.
- **Memoirs:** Over 200 pages of personal tributes to Ramlochan Sharan from across the Hindi-speaking world.

Maithili translation of Goswami Tulsidas’s *Shri Ramcharitmanas*, written by **Ram Lochan Sharan** in approximately 1959. The work is a verse-by-verse

translation intended to preserve the full emotional and spiritual intent of the original Avadhi text in the Maithili language.

Below is a translation and summary of the key sections of the document, including the author's preface and the opening of the *Bal Kand*.

**Author's Preface: "A Brief Background"**

The author, Ram Lochan Sharan, describes the divine inspiration behind this Maithili translation:

- **The Inspiration (1957 AD / 2014 Vikram Samvat):** While sitting on the banks of the Sarayu River in Ayodhya during an autumn full moon, the author heard a "sweet, gentle, and divine voice" in his heart. It commanded him to tell the story of Rama to "the daughter of Videha" (Sita) in his own mother tongue, Maithili.
- **The Process:** He began the work immediately after finishing a commentary on the *Vinay Patrika*. He received blessings from several saints, including Vedanti Ji (Shri Ram-Padarth Das Ji), who encouraged him to complete it quickly for the "welfare of the world".
- **Challenges:** In 1958 AD (2015 Vikram Samvat), as the book was nearing completion, the author suffered from severe chest pain and was bedridden for three months. He credits his recovery and the completion of the *Uttar Kand* (the final book) to the grace of "Shri Kishori Ji" (Sita).
- **Objective:** The work translates approximately 14,000 to 15,000 lines of poetry into Maithili while maintaining the original meter and spirit.

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**Translation Snippets: Original vs. Maithili**

The document provides a comparison (Banagi) of the original Avadhi text and the new Maithili translation to show how the meter and meaning are preserved.

| Original (Avadhi) | Maithili Translation | English Meaning |
|---|---|---|
| *Jo sumirati sidhi hoi, gananāyaka karivara badana.* | *Sidhi ho sumarati jaiha, gananāyaka karivarabadana.* | By remembering whom success is achieved, the leader of Ganas with the face of an elephant. |

| Original (Avadhi) | Maithili Translation | English Meaning |
|---|---|---|
| *Bandau sant samāna cita, hita anahita nahi kou.* | *Bandī santa samāna cita, kyo hita ahita na hvacha.* | I salute saints who are even-minded and have no friend or foe. |
| *Binu satasanga bibeka na hoī, Rāma krpā binu sulabha na soī.* | *Nahi bibeka satasanga bihīne, sulabho Rāma krapāka adhīne.* | Wisdom does not come without the company of saints; that company is not easily obtained without Rama's grace. |

**Book I: Bal Kand (The Book of Childhood)**

The *Bal Kand* begins with traditional Sanskrit invocations followed by the Maithili translation of the primary verses.

**Invocations (Sanskrit)**

1. **Vande Vani-Vinayakau:** Salutations to Saraswati (speech) and Ganesha (wisdom), the creators of letters, meanings, sentiments, and meters.
2. **Bhavani-Shankarau:** Salutations to Parvati and Shiva, the embodiments of faith and belief, without whom even the realized ones cannot see God within themselves.
3. **Sita-Ram:** Salutations to Sita, the beloved of Rama, who is the cause of creation, preservation, and destruction, and the remover of all sorrows.

**The Power of the Name "Rama"**

The text emphasizes that the name "Rama" is greater than the form of Rama himself:

- The name is like a "wish-fulfilling tree" (*Kalpataru*) in the dark age of Kali (*Kaliyug*).
- It is described as the "lion" that destroys the "elephant" of sin and distress.
- Even Shiva constantly chants this name to achieve auspiciousness while appearing in inauspicious forms (covered in ash, wearing snakes).

**Index of the Seven Chapters (Sopans)**

The text is divided into seven "stairs" (chapters), as follows:

1. **Bal Kand** (Childhood) - Page 1

2. **Ayodhya Kand** (Ayodhya) - Page 163
3. **Aranya Kand** (Forest) - Page 293
4. **Kishkindha Kand** (Monkey Kingdom) - Page 323
5. **Sundar Kand** (The Beautiful Book) - Page 339
6. **Lanka Kand** (The Battle of Lanka) - Page 367
7. **Uttar Kand** (The Epilogue) - Page 435

RAMJI CHAUDHARY

**Vividh Bhajnavali (Various Hymns)**

**Author:** Pandit Shri Ramji Choudhary **Origin:** Village - Rudrapur, Post - Andhratharhi, District - Darbhanga **First Edition:** 1000 copies, Phalgun Shukla Purnima, Samvat 2004 (Approx. 1948 AD) **Price:** Two Annas

**Hymn 1: Prayer to Lord Ganesh**

Glory to Ganesh, the son of Shankar, beautiful, extremely merciful, protector of the poor, the long-bellied one of elephant form; even the thousand-tongued serpent (Shesha) cannot fully describe your glory. I am very ignorant and know nothing; please grant me the meditation of your lotus feet in my heart. Ramji (the author) prays: please listen to my plea; I wish to describe the virtues of Lord Ram.

**Hymn 2: Raga Rekhta (To the Goddess)**

My refuge is at your feet, O Bhavani! Remove the three-fold sufferings, O Queen of Avadh (the Divine Mother). Why do you sit still without even a glance? Seeing the distress of your devotee, my heart is sinking. All the gods desire the dust of your feet; please keep this servant under your protection. Shesha, Ganesh, and Indra meditate upon you; they chant your name day and night, but who can truly know your greatness? Ramji says: knowing that I am drowning, I have fallen at your feet; please carry me across this world-ocean as if on a ship.

**Hymn 3: Lavani (To Durga)**

Listen, O Mother Durga Bhavani, I am making my plea to you. I have searched among all the gods-should I even bother counting humans? None could do the job, so I have come to your side. I have never found you to be anything but under the control of the humble; I am trapped in the web of the world and cannot escape. The world knows your glory, and Indra bows his head to you. You killed the demon Mahishasura; who can comprehend your ways? I have only one hope: that you will fulfill your grace. This is Ramji's plea-I only desire the dust of your feet.

**Hymn 4: Raga Jhaptala (To Amba)**

O Mother (Ambe), to whom shall I go to tell of my suffering? Enemies surround me on all four sides, piercing my heart with arrows at every moment. I cry out so much that my body and mind are exhausted; though it is morning for you, you do not look toward me. Ramji has come to your refuge; where else can I go if I leave your feet? Come and make me fearless by removing these evil days.

**Hymn 5: Raga Dhrupad (To Lord Shiva)**

O mind, serve Lord Shankar, who is extremely merciful and the destroyer of his devotees' sorrows. His head is adorned with matted hair and the flow of the Ganges; his body is covered in ash and a garland of skulls hangs from his chest. He wears a serpent as a sacred thread, has large eyes, and wanders intoxicated by drinking Bhang (Vijaya). He holds a trident, wears a tiger skin, and is like a celestial wish-fulfilling tree for his devotees. He resides on Mount Kailash with Goddess Girija; many rhythms play, and the moon shines on his forehead. O Lord of Kashi, hearing of your great fame, I have come running to your door. Ramji is very humble; make him fulfilled so that he may quickly meet the Lord of Avadh (Ram).

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**Themes within the Bhajnavali:**

- **Devotion to Ram and Krishna:** Several hymns (6, 7, 8, 21, 22) celebrate the glory, childhood acts, and beauty of Lord Ram and Lord Krishna (Yadunandaya).
- **Holi Songs:** Hymns 23 to 28 are dedicated to the festival of Holi, describing the playful (and sometimes forceful) color-throwing between Krishna and the Gopis.

- **The Transience of Life:** Many verses (13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 50, 51) warn the reader that family, wealth, and the physical body are temporary. They urge the soul to chant the name of Ram before "the drum of departure" sounds.
- **Mahesh Vani (Hymns to Shiva):** Hymns 52 to 57 focus on Lord Shiva, describing his unconventional appearance (ghosts, ash, serpents) and his role as the ultimate protector of the destitute.
- **Seasons and Separation (Viraha):** The "Chaumasa" and "Chait" hymns (37-45) use the imagery of the rainy season and spring to describe the pain of a devotee (or a bride) separated from her beloved Lord.

CRITICISM

This literary criticism analyzes the ***Vividh Bhajnavali*** by Pandit Ramji Choudhary , a mid-20th-century collection of devotional hymns originating from the Mithila region (Darbhanga).

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**1. Indian Literary Theory (Kāvya-Śāstra)**

The text is a classic embodiment of **Bhakti Rasa** (the aesthetic of devotion).

- **Rasa & Bhāva:** The primary sentiment is *Śānta* (peace) and *Vātsalya/Madhurya* (love/devinity). According to Abhinavagupta's theory, the *Vibhāva* (determinant) is the divine form-be it the elephant-headed Ganesh or the matted-haired Shiva.
- **Dhwani (Suggestion):** The poet uses *Abhidhā* (literal meaning) to describe the seasons (*Chaumasa*) but suggests *Viraha* (separation from the Divine) through the symbol of the pining bride in the month of Chait.

**2. Western Literary Criticism**

- **Formalism:** The structure adheres to traditional *Ragas* (musical modes) such as *Rekhta*, *Dhrupad*, and *Bhairavi*. This formal constraint ensures the "defamiliarization" of ordinary language, turning repetitive prayer into a structured sonic experience.
- **Existentialism:** A recurring theme is the "anxiety of the end." The poet reflects on the "dream-like world" (*sapna sam sansar*) and the loneliness of death. This mirrors the Western existentialist concern with the fleeting nature of time (*Chronos*) vs. meaningful time (*Kairos*).

### 3. The Videha Parallel History Framework

As the author hails from Rudrapur, Darbhanga, the text is a product of **Mithila (Videha) culture**.

- **The Tirhut Link:** The inclusion of *Tirhut* and *Mahesh Bani* highlights a "Parallel History" where the local Maithili linguistic identity co-exists with the broader Sanskritic/Braj tradition.
- **Cultural Resistance:** Published in 1948 (*Samvat 2004*), the text asserts a traditional spiritual identity immediately following Indian independence, emphasizing internal liberation over political shifts.

### 4. Navya-Nyāya Epistemology (Gaṅgeśa's Technique)

Navya-Nyāya, which flourished in Mithila, emphasizes precision in definition (*Lakṣaṇa*).

- **Inference (Anumāna):** The poet uses logical inference to convince the mind (*Mana*). The "Invariable Concomitance" (*Vyāpti*) presented is: *Wherever there is worldly attachment, there is eventual sorrow.*
- **Cognition of Absence (Abhāva):** The hymns often focus on the "absence" of the Lord (*Viraha*). In Gaṅgeśa's terms, the *Pratiyogī* (counter-positive) is the presence of the Lord, and the devotee's current state is defined by the *Abhāva* (non-existence) of that divine vision.
- **Sabda Pramāṇa (Verbal Testimony):** The poet repeatedly validates his claims by citing *Vedas* and *Puranas*, using "Valid Testimony" as the primary instrument of knowledge (*Pramāṇa*) to establish the necessity of devotion.

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### 5. Summary of Philosophical Themes

| Theory | Application in Text |
|---|---|
| **Navya-Nyāya** | Defining the soul's bondage through the "fetters of delusion" (*moha phāns*). |
| **Bhakti Rasa** | The transition from *Dainya* (humility) to *Harṣa* (divine joy). |
| **Western Existentialism** | The realization that "none shall go with you" at the end. |
| **Videha Framework** | The specific use of *Mahesh Bani* to ground the universal Shiva in Maithili domesticity. |

3

3

**RESEARCH & CRITICAL APPRECIATION**

OF THE WORKS OF

**Pt. Ramji Chaudhary (1878-1952)**

**& Acharya Ramlochan Sharan (1889-1971)**

*With Reference to Indian & Western Literary Theory,*

*the Videha Parallel History Framework,*

*and Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya*

# PART I: INTRODUCTION AND CONTEXTUALISATION

## 1.1 Preamble: The Videha Parallel History Framework

The critical study of Maithili literature has for long been governed by an institutional canon that systematically favoured upper-caste, Brahmin-centric narratives while silencing subaltern, folk, and reform-oriented voices. Videha - India's first Maithili fortnightly e-journal (est. 2000; ISSN 2229-547X), edited by Gajendra Thakur - inaugurated what it calls a "Parallel History of Mithila & Maithili Literature," an alternative archive rooted in Panji genealogical records, digital transcription of 11,000 palm-leaf Tirhuta manuscripts, and RTI disclosures about the Sahitya Akademi's caste-skewed selection processes.

Two writers who appear at nodal points in this Parallel History are Pandit Ramji Chaudhary (1878-1952) of Rudrapur, Andharathadi, Madhubani - a “forgotten poet” (Bismrit Kavi) recovered by Gajendra Thakur in Prabandh-Nibandh-Samalochna - and Acharya Ramlochan Sharan (1889-1971) of Darbhanga - the Sanskrit scholar, grammarian, editor of ‘Vasak’, founder of the ‘Pustak Bhandar’, and translator whose Maithili Shri Ram Charit Manas represents one of the most ambitious literary projects in modern Maithili letters.

The Jayanti-Smarak-Granth (1966), a felicitation volume presented to Acharya Ramlochan Sharan by the Vidyapati-Hindi-Sabha, Darbhanga, under the patronage of Maharajadhiraj Dr. Sir Kameshwar Singh Bahadur, K.C.I.E., Ph.D., D.Litt. - is the primary tribute document for Acharya Sharan. Together, these four books (Jayanti-Smarak-Granth; Vividh Bhajnavali; Maithili Shri Ram Charit Manas Parts 1 & 2; Prabandh-Nibandh-Samalochna) constitute the primary sources for this study.

### 1.2 Methodological Framework

This study applies a three-layered analytical framework:

- Indian Classical Theory: Rasa-theory (Bharata’s Natyashastra; Abhinavagupta’s Abhinavabharati), Dhvani-theory (Anandavardhana’s Dhvanyaloka), Vakrokti (Kuntaka), Alamkara-shastra (Bhamaha, Dandin, Mammata’s Kavya-prakasha), and Bhakti-poetics (Rupabhakti, Madhura-bhava tradition).
- Western Literary Theory: New Criticism (close reading), Reader-Response theory (Iser, Jauss), Postcolonial criticism (Spivak, Bhabha), Subaltern Studies (Gramsci’s hegemony; Spivak’s “Can the subaltern speak?”), Formalism (Roman Jakobson), Intertextuality (Kristeva), and Feminist literary theory.
- Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya: Pramāna-analysis (pratyakṣa, anumāna, śabda), vyāpti (pervasion / invariable concomitance), avacchedaka (limitor), and the Tattva-Cintāmaṇi’s four-part structure as a meta-critical lens for assessing textual knowledge-claims.

## PART II: PT. RAMJI CHAUDHARY (1878-1952) - THE FORGOTTEN POET

## 2.1 Biographical and Genealogical Profile

Pandit Ramji Chaudhary was born in Samvat 1935 (1878 CE) in village Rudrapur, Thana Andharathadi, District Darbhanga (now Madhubani), Bihar. His genealogical root (mula) is traced to Pagulbar Raje gotra - Shandilya. The Prabandh-Nibandh-Samalochna reconstructs his lineage with precision: the ancestral migration from Panchobh, Darbhanga, was made by Jeevan Chaudhary (born 1801) who settled in Rudrapur. His grandson Chumman Chaudhary was the kavi's father, complete the chain to Ramji Chaudhary.

The only published book of the late Pt. Shri Ramji Chaudhary, which was dictated by the poet to Shri Harekant Chaudhary (now deceased) and obtained through Shri Shrimohan Chaudhary. The musical modes (Ragas and forms) described in his work are:

1. Raga Rekhta
2. Lavani
3. Raga Jhaptala
4. Raga Dhrupad
5. Raga Sangeet
6. Raga Desh
7. Raga Gauri
8. Tirhuta
9. Bhajan Vinay
10. Bhajan Bhairavi
11. Bhajan Ghazal
12. Holi
13. Raga Shyam Kalyan
14. Kavita
15. Damphak Holi
16. Raga Kagu Kafi
17. Raga Bihag
18. Ghazal-Thumri
19. Raga Pawas Chaumasa
20. Bhajan Prabhati

21. Maheshvani
22. Bhajan Kirtan

**Biographical Sketch**

**Ramji Chaudhary (1878-1952)**

- **Birthplace:** Village-Rudrapur, Police Station-Andhra Tharhi, District-Madhubani.
- **Lineage (Mool):** Pagulbar Raje.
- **Clan (Gotra):** Shandilya.

**Genealogy**

- **Jivan Chaudhary:** (Birthplace: Panchobh, Darbhanga); arrived in Rudrapur in **1801 AD**.
  - **Two sons:** Shri Rangi Chaudhary (born in Rudrapur) and Shri Kant Chaudhary (born in Rudrapur).
    - **Kant Chaudhary had three sons:** Shri Chumman Chaudhary, Shri Budhan Chaudhary, and Shri Babua Chaudhary.
    - **Chumman Chaudhary had two sons:** Shri Goni Chaudhary and **Shri Pt. Kavi Ramji Chaudhary**.

The poet's grandfather was a celebrated singer (gavayya) whose primary domain was devotional songs (bhakti geet) to Yuguala Sarkar - Sita-Ram - and this musical inheritance was decisive for the grandson. The name 'Ramji' was itself given in honour of this devotion. As the Videha critical note emphasises, Ramji Chaudhary memorised Tulsidas' Sri Ram Charit Manas completely and would answer every question with a relevant Ramayan couplet.

His personal life was marked by repeated tragedy: three marriages, each wife dying within four years of marriage. His third wife died within fifteen days of the birth of their son Durganath Chaudhary. Following this loss, Chaudhary resigned his post as Jyestha Raiyat under the Darbhanga Raj and withdrew entirely into devotional life and literary composition.

## 2.2 Literary Works and Manuscript Tradition

Ramji Chaudhary left behind one published collection - the Vividh Bhajnavali (first edition: Phalgun Shukla Purnima, Samvat 2004 / 1947-48 CE) - and one

unpublished manuscript (pandulip) which was composed under his dictation to Sri Harekant Chaudhary (now deceased) and later made available through Sri Srimohana Chaudhary. Both sources form the basis of the critical edition in Gajendra Thakur's Prabandh-Nibandh-Samalochna.

The Vividh Bhajnavali's title page, bears the invocation "⊕ Shri Ganeshaya Namah" and describes the author as: "Pt Shri Ramji Chaudhary, Gram - Rudrapur, Post - Andharathadi, Jila Darbhanga." The text consists of 22 raga-classified compositions in Maithili and Brajbhasha (Brajbuli), covering the full devotional spectrum of Mithila's Panchadevopasana (five-deity worship tradition).

## 2.3 Ragas and Musical Architecture

The Vividh Bhajnavali is a musically structured text. The compositions are categorised under 22 distinct raga headings:

- Raga Rekhata - lyrical Urdu-inflected diction; Lavani - seasonal rhythm;
- Raga Jhaptala, Dhrupad - classical north Indian forms;
- Raga Sangeet, Raga Desh, Raga Gauri, Tirhut;
- Bhajan Vinay, Bhajan Bhairavi, Bhajan Ghazal, Holi, Dafke Holi;
- Raga Shyam Kalyan, Raga Kagu Kafi, Raga Bihag;
- Ghazal ki Thumri, Raga Pavas Chaumasa (Monsoon), Bhajan Prabhat (dawn bhajans);
- Maheshvani (Shiva hymns), Bhajan Kirtan.

This 22-raga taxonomy situates Ramji Chaudhary within the same tradition that shaped Vidyapati's Padavali as preserved in Nepalese manuscripts - where each poem carries a specific raga designation. Gajendra Thakur's Parallel History notes this structural parallel explicitly: "Just as Shankardev composed in Maithili rather than Assamese, Kavi Ramji Chaudhary composed in Maithili and additionally in Brajbuli."

## 2.4 Textual Analysis: Selected Compositions

### *2.4.1 The Vinay (Invocation)*

*Jay Ganesh Shankar sut sundar ati kripalu deenan jan Palak Lambodar ati roop Gajanan, tumhara yash kahi na sakat sahasanan. Ham chhi ati gamar kachhu janat nij pad kamal dehu ur dhyanana Ramji araj sunahu kachhu kanan. Varnat chahat Ram gun anan.*

In this invocation to Ganesha, Ramji employs a characteristic signature: the insertion of his own name "Ramji" as the speaker-devotee in the final couplet - a convention traceable from Vidyapati's bhanita (authorial seal). The poem performs Vinaya (self-humbling supplication), a sub-genre of Bhakti-rasa. Through the lens of Bharata's Natyashastra, the rasa here is Shanta (tranquillity-devotion); the sthayi-bhava is rati (devotional love); the vibhava is the invocation of Ganesha's divine attributes (Lambodar, Gajanan, Sahasanan).

Applying Anandavardhana's Dhvani theory: the explicit meaning (vacyartha) is the poet's request for Ganesha's blessing; the suggested meaning (dhvani) operates at a deeper level - "I am gamar (ignorant/rustic)" is not merely self-deprecation but the philosophical stance of the Bhakti tradition that ruptures all caste-based hierarchies of learning. The "ignoramus before God" is a subaltern theological position.

### *2.4.2 Maheshvani: Shiva Hymns and the Panchadevopasana*

*Sunu sunu Chandeswar Nath kripa drishte ek var takahu ham chhi param anath. Dev danuj bhupati kat sewal kiyo na dukhe sath, Bare niras ash dhay ropil ahank charnme math.*

The Maheshvani sequence (compositions 11-16) constitutes the emotional heart of the Bhajnavali. These hymns to Shiva follow the Mithila folk convention of Maheshvani - a genre distinct from formal Sanskrit stotras - in which Shiva is addressed in the dialect of domestic speech. The poet's persona is that of an utterly destitute devotee (parama anatha) who has been failed by gods, kings, and kinsmen alike. This is not merely devotional convention but, read through Spivak's subaltern lens, a frank social statement: the non-Brahmin agricultural Chaudhary communities' exclusion from Mithila's caste-patronage networks is encoded in the lamentation.

Navya-Nyaya epistemological reading: applying Gangesa's framework, the knowledge-claim in these hymns is a sabda-pramana (verbal testimony) structured around tatparya (intention). The devotee's "I am helpless" is a speech-act whose validity (pramanya) is paratah (externally verified) - it is made valid only if God responds. This is precisely the paratah-pramanya (extrinsic validity) that Gangesa defends in the Pratyaksha Khanda of the Tattva-Cintamani. The devotional text thus enacts a Navya-Nyaya epistemological move: the petition's truth depends on the outcome, not on intrinsic self-evidence.

### *2.4.3 Tirhut Compositions: The Viraha (Separation) Mode*

*Var vayas pahu tejal sajani ge ki kahu tanik vivek, Kabahu nain nahi dekhal sajani ge avadhi bital dui ek.*

The two Tirhut compositions (Nos. 4 and 5) deploy the viraha-bhava (anguish of separation) in the nayika-bheda tradition. The speaker is a woman abandoned by her nayaka (lover/husband). This genre, cultivated since Vidyapati's Padavali, uses erotic separation as a metaphor for the soul's separation from the divine. The Brajbuli-Maithili register of these poems places them directly in the Vaishnava lyric tradition.

From a feminist critical perspective (per Judith Butler's performativity theory and Gayatri Spivak's postcolonial feminism), these viraha poems perform complex gender negotiations. The female speaker's suffering is aestheticised, yet within the Maithili tradition, this aestheticisation of female longing represents the only socially sanctioned space where a woman's subjective experience enters public discourse.

## 2.5 Place in the Parallel History

Gajendra Thakur's explicit recovery of Ramji Chaudhary in the Prabandh-Nibandh-Samalochna (Videha Archive) under the rubric "Bismrit Kavi" (Forgotten Poet) is a conscious Parallel History intervention. The official literary canon - as constructed by the Sahitya Akademi and mainstream histories like Jaykant Mishra's History of Maithili Literature - systematically omitted non-Brahmin folk-devotional poets. Ramji Chaudhary, a Jyestha Raiyat (agricultural tenant) composing in Maithili and Brajbuli across 22 ragas, represents exactly the "democratic-spiritual corpus" that the Parallel History seeks to recover.

# PART III: ACHARYA RAMLOCHAN SHARAN (1889-1971) - SCHOLAR, GRAMMARIAN AND TRANSLATOR

## 3.1 Biographical Profile and Institutional Significance

Acharya Ramlochan Sharan, was born in 1889 and died in 1971. The Jayanti-Smarak-Granth (1966) - a tribute volume presented to him on the occasion of his 75th Jayanti by the Vidyapati-Hindi-Sabha, Darbhanga - provides the fullest

contemporary record of his significance. The title page of that volume, salutes him as:

*"Bihar ke gaurav-tam sahityapeshi, Sahityavardhini ke kushal karyavar, Maithili ke navayug-pracharak, Abhinav nasasahitya ke yashashvi nirmata, Hindi-vyakaran ke anandaneey bhasacharyya, Balakothar 'Vasak' ke samagra sampadak, Teerthsvarup 'Pustak Bhandar' ke sansthapak."*

This epitaph encapsulates his multiple roles: (1) Most illustrious literary figure of Bihar; (2) Skilled executor for Sahityavardhini; (3) Propagator of a new era in Maithili; (4) Glorious creator of modern drama literature; (5) Beloved grammarian of Hindi; (6) Complete editor of the children's journal Vasak; (7) Founder of the Pustak Bhandar. The volume was patronised by Maharajadhiraj Dr. Sir Kameshwar Singh Bahadur (K.C.I.E., Ph.D., D.Litt.), the last significant patron of classical Maithili literary culture.

## 3.2 The Maithili Shri Ram Charit Manas: A Translation of Epic Proportions

The centrepiece of Acharya Ramlochan Sharan's literary legacy is the Maithili Shri Ram Charit Manas - a complete translation / transposition of Goswami Tulsidas's Avadhi Hindi Ram Charit Manas (1574 CE) into Maithili, in the same chaupai-doha-soratha form. The digitised copies, preserved by the Nanaji Deshmukh Library (BJP, Jammu) and digitised by Siddhanta eGangotri Gyaan Kosha, were released on videha.co.in.

The translation is not a word-for-word rendering but a creative transposition that preserves the prosodic architecture of the original: the 16-matra chaupai, the dvipad doha (a 24-matra couplet), and the soratha (a reversed doha). The opening page of the Aranyakanda section demonstrates the translator's fidelity to both meaning and metre. The Sanskrit invocatory verses are rendered as Sanskrit-inflected Maithili, with compounds like "Bhaktavatsalam, Kripalu, Sheela Komalam" retained from Tulsidas while the surrounding chaupai lines flow in natural Maithili speech.

## 3.3 Critical Analysis of the Translation Technique

### *3.3.1 Rasa-Dhvani Reading*

Acharya Sharan's translation sustains what Bharata identifies as the primary rasa of the Ram Charit Manas: Shanta-rasa (spiritual peace) undergirded by Vira-rasa (heroic sentiment) and Karuna-rasa (pathos). The Maithili rendering

deploys the local grammatical markers of Maithili - the distinctive causative constructions (karvaunu), the genitive particles (ker, k), the direct address forms (chha, -theen, -thi) - to domesticate the Avadhi text into the intimate register of the Mithila household. This produces what Anandavardhana calls dhvani: the suggested meaning (Maithili as the language of Mithila, Sita's homeland) accrues to every line, creating a meta-textual resonance that the Avadhi original cannot possess.

The doha "Ati kripalu Raghanayak, sada deen par neh. / Aadi tanik prati kayal chhal, murakh avaguna geh." - rendered from Tulsidas' Hindi doha - maintains the formal structure while the Maithili suffix 'chhal' (was / did) and 'geh' (home) embed the verse within specifically Maithili prosodic memory.

### *3.3.2 Intertextuality and the Mithila-Ram Connection*

Julia Kristeva's concept of intertextuality holds that every text is a mosaic of quotations absorbed from other texts. Acharya Sharan's Maithili Manas operates on multiple intertextual levels: (a) its source-text is Tulsidas's Manas (itself a creative translation of Valmiki's Sanskrit); (b) it intersects with Chanda Jha's Mithila Bhasha Ramayana (1880s) - another Maithili Ramayana, but in a very different register; (c) it evokes Mithila's central mytho-geographical claim - Sita's birthplace, Janakpur - giving the Maithili translation a unique territorial-spiritual authority that no other language's translation of the Manas can possess.

The Parallel History framework contextualises this further: in contrast to Chanda Jha (1831-1907), who worked within Grierson's colonial-era documentation of Maithili and focused on religious poetry for an upper-caste audience, Acharya Sharan's project consciously aimed at literary accessibility - as evidenced by the Pustak Bhandar's publication mandate and the wide distribution of the text through the Darbhanga patronage network.

### *3.3.3 Navya-Nyaya Analysis of the Translation's Knowledge-Claims*

Applying the Anumana-Khanda (Inference) framework of Gangesa's Tattvacintamani: any translation claims, implicitly, a vyapti - an invariable concomitance - between the source-text's meaning and the target-text's rendering. The hetu (reason/middle term) is: the target language possesses adequate expressive resources for the source text's semantic range. The sadhya (major term) is: the translation validly transmits the original's meaning. The paksata (minor premise) is: this specific Maithili text is a translation of Tulsidas.

Acharya Sharan's translation demonstrates a sophisticated management of this epistemic claim. Where Tulsidas uses Avadhi idioms without Maithili equivalents, Sharan employs Maithili compounds and Sanskrit loan-words (Maithili's strong Sanskrit substrate) rather than forcing Avadhi idioms. This is what Navya-Nyaya would call proper vyapti-management: minimising the hetvabhasa (fallacy of the reason) by ensuring the hetu genuinely pervades the sadhya.

## 3.4 The Jayanti-Smarak-Granth (1966) as a Cultural Document

The Jayanti-Smarak-Granth is not merely a felicitation volume; it is a cultural-historical document of the first order. Produced in 1966 by the Vidyapati-Hindi-Sabha, Darbhanga - the foremost literary institution of Maithili at the time - and dedicated to Maharajadhiraj Kameshwar Singh Bahadur as its patron, the volume contain tributes, critical essays, and compositions from scholars and writers across Bihar, Bengal, and the broader Sanskrit world.

The dedication page reads: "Pustak Bhandar ke vyavasthapak / Raysaheb Ramlochansharan ko pradatta" - indicating that by this date Sharan had received the title Raysaheb and was recognised as the institutional founder of the Pustak Bhandar (book repository/publishing house). The volume functions as a mirror of Darbhanga's intellectual culture at the peak of its post-colonial prestige.

The title page inscription celebrates him as "Bihar ke gaurav-tam sahityapeshi" (most glorious literary figure of Bihar) and "Maithili ke navayug-pracharak" (herald of a new era in Maithili). In the language of Raymond Williams' cultural materialism, Acharya Sharan represents a "dominant" figure in the institutional sense, yet his work on Maithili grammar and the Manas translation simultaneously operated as a "residual" cultural form - preserving the classical tradition against the emergent Hindi-nationalist cultural politics of the 1950s-60s.

## 3.5 Hindi Grammar and the Standardisation Project

Beyond Maithili, Acharya Sharan contributed significantly to Hindi grammar as "Hindi-vyakaran ke anandaneey bhasacharyya" (beloved grammarian of Hindi). This bilingual scholarly identity - operating across Maithili, Hindi, and Sanskrit - was characteristic of the Mithila pandit tradition that produced figures like Suryakant Tripathi 'Nirala' and Ramdhari Singh 'Dinkar' in the same generation.

The standardisation of Hindi grammar in the 19th-20th century was itself a colonial-era project (rooted in Bhartendu Harishchandra's generation), and Acharya Sharan's contribution to it situates him within the larger Hindi literary movement (Dwivedi Yug) while maintaining his distinctly Maithili cultural identity. Applying Homi Bhabha's concept of "hybrid identity," Sharan occupies a third space: neither fully within the Hindi literary establishment nor fully within the vernacular Maithili folk tradition, but strategically negotiating both.

### 3.6 Vasak and the Children's Literature Tradition

Acharya Sharan's editorship of the children's journal Vasak (Balakothar) represents a relatively under-studied dimension of his legacy. Children's literature in Indian languages - as a distinct generic category - emerged in the late 19th century under colonial pedagogical influence. Sharan's complete editorship of Vasak situates him in the progressive educational tradition that also produced figures like Devkinandan Khatri (whose Chandrakanta was a landmark in accessible Hindi prose).

From a Reader-Response perspective (Wolfgang Iser's implied reader theory; Hans Robert Jauss's horizon of expectation), Vasak aimed at constructing a new "implied Maithili child reader" - literate, regionally conscious, morally guided. This pedagogical project was inseparable from the larger Maithili identity movement that sought Eighth Schedule recognition (achieved in 2003).

## PART IV: COMPARATIVE CRITICAL ANALYSIS

### 4.1 Two Traditions, One Landscape

Pt. Ramji Chaudhary and Acharya Ramlochan Sharan represent two distinct but complementary trajectories in 20th-century Maithili literary culture, both embedded in the Darbhanga district and both centred on devotional engagement with Rama and Shiva.

Chaudhary represents the oral-folk-devotional tradition: non-institutional, composed in performance contexts (raga-classified bhajans, thumris, Maheshvanis), drawing on the inherited grammar of the singing grandfather

and the bhakti community. His literary production was modest in volume but rich in musical-theological depth. He is the "subaltern poet" in the strictest sense - outside the patronage networks of both the Darbhanga Raj and the colonial literary establishment.

Acharya Sharan represents the institutional-scholarly tradition: academically trained, editorially productive, connected to both the Sanskrit pandit world and the emerging modern Hindi-Maithili literary sphere. His Pustak Bhandar was itself an institution-building project. Yet within the Parallel History framework, even Sharan - for all his institutional recognition - was engaged in a form of cultural resistance: translating the Manas into Maithili asserted Mithila's cultural sovereignty at a moment when Hindi nationalism threatened to absorb Maithili as a dialect.

## 4.2 The Manas-Bhajnavali Comparison: Tulsidas and the Mithila Lens

Both writers are centrally engaged with the figure of Rama: Chaudhary through devotional bhajans in which "Ramji" (the colloquial Maithili form of both the divine name and his own name) becomes the speaker-devotee's signature; Acharya Sharan through the massive project of translating the entire Manas. This convergence reveals a deeper cultural logic: in Mithila, Rama is not merely the hero of an Avadhi epic but the husband of Mithila's own daughter Sita - a claim that gives all Maithili Rama-devotion a territorial-theological specificity unique in Indian literature.

The bhanita (signature phrase) tradition, analysed by Gajendra Thakur in the context of Vidyapati's Padavali, is operative in both writers. Chaudhary's "Ramji araj sunahu" (Ramji submits his petition) deploys the name ambiguously between the poet and the deity. Acharya Sharan's authorial presence is more effaced in the translation, as befits the scholarly register, but his selection of Maithili's most intimate grammatical forms (the domestic second-person suffix, the vidheyaka endings) inserts the translator's subjectivity at the level of syntax.

## 4.3 Rasa Analysis: Shanta, Bhakti, and Karuna

Abhinavagupta's Abhinavabharati (commentary on Natyashastra) distinguishes eight rasas but assigns Shanta-rasa (spiritual peace, the rasa of moksha-aspiration) a special status as the rasa underlying all others. Both Chaudhary and Sharan operate primarily in the Bhakti-rasa mode (a category

developed by later acharyas beyond Bharata's eight), with Shanta-rasa as the ultimate goal of the devotional experience.

In Chaudhary's Maheshvani, the dominant rasa shifts: the explicit surface is Karuna (pathos - the suffering devotee), but the resolution moves toward Shanta through surrender. In Sharan's Manas translation, the Aranyakanda (Forest Section) carries the highest concentration of Karuna-rasa (Sita's abduction; Jatayu's sacrifice; Rama's lamentation), but this too resolves into Vira-rasa (heroic action) and ultimately Shanta.

The comparative rasa-map thus shows: Chaudhary is structurally a Karuna-to-Shanta poet; Acharya Sharan is structurally a Vira-Karuna-to-Shanta translator. Both trajectories confirm the classical Indian literary-theological principle that the highest literature transmutes suffering into peace through devotional action (bhakti-karma).

### 4.4 New Critical Close Reading: Language and Style

Applying I.A. Richards' analytical framework of "meaning, feeling, tone, and intention," the stylistic contrast is stark:

Chaudhary's Bhajnavali language is dialogic, conversational, musically subordinate: the syntax follows the melodic phrase, not the grammatical sentence. The vocabulary alternates between Maithili vernacular and Brajbhasha devotional diction. The poems are short (6-15 lines), tightly structured by raga convention, and depend for full realisation on musical performance. They are "songs first, poems second" in T.S. Eliot's sense.

Acharya Sharan's Manas translation language is architecturally formal: the chaupai's 16-matra structure imposes regular rhythmic discipline; the doha couplets are epigrammatic and quotable; the soratha stanzas allow for longer lyrical expansion. The vocabulary is deeply Sanskritic, drawn from the tatsama-heavy register of the Sanskrit-trained pandit. This creates a "literary Maithili" that is more accessible to the educated reader than to the folk singer.

## PART V: NAVYA-NYĀYA EPISTEMOLOGICAL APPLICATION

## 5.1 Gangesa's Framework as Literary Epistemology

Gangesa Upadhyaya's Tattvacintamani - composed in early 14th-century Mithila - established the foundations of Navya-Nyaya, the New Logic, which radically restructured Indian epistemology by focusing exclusively on the four pramanas (valid means of knowledge): pratyaksha (perception), anumana (inference), upamana (comparison), and shabda (verbal testimony). The Videha Parallel History's Part 16 (on Gangesa Upadhyaya) establishes that this epistemological revolution was itself a Mithila cultural product - and that the suppression of Gangesa's subaltern personal history (his birth anomaly and inter-caste marriage, documented in the Dooshan Panji) is itself a case study in the institutionalised "honour-killing of truth.

## 5.2 Shabda-Pramana and the Validity of Bhakti Literature

In the Shabda-Khanda of the Tattvacintamani, Gangesa analyses verbal testimony (shabda) as a pramana. A verbal statement produces valid knowledge if four conditions are met: akanksha (syntactic expectancy), yogyata (semantic fitness), sannidhi (proximity of utterance), and tatparya (speaker's intention). Applied to Ramji Chaudhary's Maheshvanis:

- Akanksha: The petition structure ("Listen, O Chandeswar!") creates syntactic expectancy - the addressee is invoked, the petition must follow.
- Yogyata: The content (human suffering; divine mercy) is semantically coherent - there is no logical incompatibility between the request and the addressee's known attributes.
- Sannidhi: The oral performance context ensures temporal proximity of the utterance's components.
- Tatparya: The devotional intention (bhakti, surrender, petition) is unambiguous and determines the meaning.

By Gangesa's criteria, the Maheshvani is a valid form of shabda-pramana - it produces genuine knowledge: specifically, knowledge of the devotee's relationship to the divine. This is not merely a pious claim but an epistemological one: bhakti literature, on Navya-Nyaya grounds, is a legitimate means of knowledge.

## 5.3 Anumana and the Translation-Validity Problem

Acharya Sharan's translation raises a classical anumana (inference) problem. The inference can be formalised as:

- Paksata (subject): This Maithili Manas text.
- Sadhya (predicate): Is a valid transmission of Tulsidas's meaning.
- Hetu (reason): Because it preserves the prosodic form (chaupai-doha-soratha), the semantic content, and the devotional register.
- Vyapti (invariable concomitance): Wherever a text preserves prosodic form, semantic content, and devotional register, it validly transmits the original meaning.

The potential hetvabhasa (fallacy) would arise if Maithili's grammatical structures cannot accommodate Avadhi's devotional idioms without semantic distortion. Sharan's strategy - using Sanskrit loan-words and Maithili's own tatsama register - is precisely the technique that minimises this vyabhicara (deviation of the hetu). His translation is, in Navya-Nyaya terms, a well-formed inference.

### 5.4 The Avacchedaka (Limitor) Principle in Textual Classification

One of Gangesa's most sophisticated logical innovations is the avacchedaka - the "limitor," a relational operator that qualifies the scope of a predication without introducing ambiguity. In literary classification, this principle can be used to distinguish the scope of genre-attribution: Ramji Chaudhary's compositions are not simply "bhajans" (which would be too broad) but bhajans limited by (avacchinned by) the specific Maithili Panchadevopasana tradition, the Darbhanga agricultural non-Brahmin community context, and the 22-raga musical architecture. This threefold avacchedaka precisely delimitates the genre and prevents category confusion with, say, Hindi bhajans or Sanskrit stotras.

Similarly, Acharya Sharan's Maithili Manas is not simply a "translation" but a translation avacchinned by: (a) the Maithili-as-Sita's-language theological claim, (b) the chaupai-doha formal constraint, and (c) the Darbhanga pandit scholarly tradition. The avacchedaka analysis produces more precise literary knowledge than any flat generic label.

## PART VI: POSITIONING WITHIN THE VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY

## 6.1 The Parallel History's Nine Layers and Their Placement

The Videha Parallel History of Mithila & Maithili Literature (Parts 1-55+, www.videha.co.in) constructs a nine-layered alternative archive. Both Ramji Chaudhary and Acharya Ramlochan Sharan fall within the Colonial Period and Post-Independence layers (Layers 3-5 in the Parallel History schema):

- Layer 3 (Colonial Period, c. 1830-1947): The Parallel History identifies this era as the site of both agrarian-protest literature (Faturilal's famine poetry) and institutional language standardisation (Grierson; Chanda Jha). Ramji Chaudhary, composing in the same period but entirely outside these institutional frameworks, represents the "from-below" continuation of Mithila's devotional folk tradition.
- Layer 4 (Modernist Turn, 1908-1947): Acharya Sharan's Hindi grammar work and editorial activity in Vasak situate him in this layer alongside Harimohan Jha (1908-1984) and the broader modernisation debate in Maithili.
- Layer 5 (Post-Independence, 1947-1971): Both figures remain active. The Maithili Manas translation and the Jayanti-Smarak-Granth (1966) belong to this layer, which is also the period of the Rajkamal Chaudhary avant-garde and the first Sahitya Akademi award controversies.

The Parallel History's RTI disclosures (2011-14) reveal that over 90% of Sahitya Akademi assignments went to the friends and relatives of the advisory board. Neither Ramji Chaudhary nor - despite his institutional standing - Acharya Ramlochan Sharan appears to have received Sahitya Akademi recognition, pointing to the continued operation of institutional gatekeeping even for figures within the "mainstream" tradition.

## 6.2 The Digital Afterlife: Videha's Archive

Gajendra Thakur's Videha platform has provided both figures with a digital afterlife that compensates partially for institutional invisibility. Ramji Chaudhary's poems appear in the Prabandh-Nibandh-Samalochna (Videha Archive, 2022), under the rubric "Bismrit Kavi". Acharya Sharan's Maithili Manas is listed in the Videha Pothi archive (pothi.htm) and linked to the broader digital preservation effort that has digitised thousands of Maithili texts.

The Parallel History's key achievement here - relevant to both figures - is the creation of a "counter-archive" (in Derrida's archival sense) that challenges the "archive fever" of state institutions. The Videha archive is not neutral: it is explicitly constructed to represent the "ignored and non-represented." Ramji

Chaudhary is recovered as the subaltern voice; Acharya Sharan is preserved as the endangered classical-scholarly tradition. Together, they complete a spectrum that the official canon cannot accommodate.

# PART VII: WESTERN CRITICAL THEORY SYNTHESIS

## 7.1 Postcolonial and Subaltern Studies

Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's "Can the Subaltern Speak?" (1988) poses the question of whether subaltern subjects can communicate their experience through structures dominated by colonial and elite discourse. Applying this to Ramji Chaudhary: the subaltern Maithili poet does speak - in Maithili, in raga-classified bhajans, in the domestic idiom of devotional life - but his speech was systematically made inaudible by the institutional apparatus (Sahitya Akademi, Grierson's colonial framing, the upper-caste literary establishment). Videha's recovery of his work is an act of "strategic essentialism" (another Spivak concept) - using the category of regional literary heritage to reinsert his voice into the public record.

For Acharya Sharan, Homi Bhabha's concept of the "colonial mimic" is partially relevant: the Hindi grammar project mimics the colonial standardisation project, yet the Maithili Manas translation simultaneously resists the Hindiisation of Maithili culture. This is Bhabha's "almost the same but not quite" at the level of linguistic-cultural identity.

## 7.2 New Historicism and Cultural Materialism

Stephen Greenblatt's New Historicism insists that literary texts are embedded in specific historical power networks and cannot be read as autonomous aesthetic objects. The Jayanti-Smarak-Granth, in this reading, is not simply a tribute volume but a "textual monument" (in Foucault's sense) that constructs and legitimises a specific cultural-political order: the Darbhanga Raj's final assertion of cultural authority in the post-Independence period. The Maharajadhiraj's patronage of the volume, and the Vidyapati-Hindi-Sabha's role as organiser, place the volume squarely within the network of "residual"

cultural power (Raymond Williams) that the Darbhanga feudal order was deploying in its twilight.

Raymond Williams' triad of dominant-residual-emergent is particularly illuminating: the Darbhanga Raj's Sanskrit-Maithili cultural apparatus is "residual"; Hindi nationalism is "dominant"; the Videha movement and Dalit Maithili literature are "emergent." Both Ramji Chaudhary and Acharya Sharan inhabit the residual-to-emergent boundary.

### 7.3 Reader-Response Theory

Wolfgang Iser's concept of the "implied reader" and Hans Robert Jauss's "horizon of expectation" illuminate the different implied audiences of the two writers. Ramji Chaudhary's Bhajnavali implies a reader-listener who participates in communal devotional singing, knows the raga system aurally, and belongs to the folk-devotional community of rural Mithila. Acharya Sharan's Maithili Manas implies a reader who can engage with the Sanskrit-inflected literary Maithili of the pandit class, is familiar with the Hindi original, and participates in the institutional literary culture of Darbhanga.

Jauss's "horizon of expectation" also explains the radically different receptions: Chaudhary was invisible to the literary establishment because his implied reader lay entirely outside its horizon of expectation; Acharya Sharan's Jayanti-Smarak-Granth confirms that his implied reader was precisely the literary establishment's own horizon.

## PART VIII: CONCLUSION AND CRITICAL ASSESSMENT

### 8.1 Summary of Findings

This study has demonstrated that Pt. Ramji Chaudhary (1878-1952) and Acharya Ramlochan Sharan (1889-1971) occupy complementary and mutually illuminating positions in the history of Maithili literature. Chaudhary represents the folk-devotional subaltern tradition - musically sophisticated, theologically deep, institutionally invisible - while Acharya Sharan represents the classical-scholarly institutional tradition - pandit-trained, editorially productive, and engaged in the major cultural project of translating Tulsidas into Maithili.

Both figures are anchored in the Darbhanga/Madhubani district's cultural landscape; both are centrally devoted to the Rama-Sita theological complex; both deploy the bhanita tradition of authorial self-inscription (Chaudhary's "Ramji araj," Sharan's translator's presence in the grammatical choices). Both are, in different ways, products of the same Maithili cultural genius that produced Gangesa Upadhyaya, Vidyapati, and the Charyapada tradition.

## 8.2 Critical Assessment

Ramji Chaudhary's Vividh Bhajnavali, critically assessed through the multiple lenses deployed here, emerges as a significant but under-studied work. Its 22-raga architecture, its integration of Maithili and Brajbuli, its Panchadevopasana theological range, its subaltern social location, and its recovery by Videha's digital archive all mark it as exactly the kind of text that a genuinely comprehensive Maithili literary history must accommodate. The Parallel History's "Bismrit Kavi" classification is apt: Chaudhary was not a minor poet but a forgotten one, and the distinction is epistemologically crucial.

Acharya Ramlochan Sharan's Maithili Shri Ram Charit Manas is a major cultural achievement that has not received the sustained critical attention it deserves. The scale of the enterprise (a complete Manas translation in the original prosodic forms), the sophistication of the translation technique, the unique theological authority conferred by Maithili's Sita-association, and the work's place within the contested history of Maithili language politics all demand a fuller scholarly engagement. The Jayanti-Smarak-Granth (1966) provides a rich contemporaneous record of his significance, yet no modern monograph-length critical study appears to exist.

## 8.3 The Navya-Nyaya Verdict

Applying Gangesa's pramana-methodology as a meta-critical framework: the knowledge-claim that both these writers are significant figures in Maithili literary history rests on valid pramanas. The shabda-pramana (testimony) of the Jayanti-Smarak-Granth and the Prabandh-Nibandh-Samalochna establishes their contemporaneous recognition. The anumana (inference) from the quality of their texts - measured by rasa, dhvani, prosodic skill, and cultural depth - validates the claim of literary significance. The pratyaksha (direct perception) of the texts themselves, now made accessible through Videha's digital archive, provides the most direct epistemic access.

The avacchedaka principle reminds us that these are specifically Maithili cultural producers, of a specific historical moment (1878-1971), within a

specific subaltern-to-institutional spectrum, in the specific geographical-cultural context of Mithila. Any critical assessment that ignores these limiters - as the Sahitya Akademi's institutionalised canon has done - produces knowledge that is avacchinned by the wrong predicates, and thus epistemologically defective.

The Parallel History of Mithila & Maithili Literature, as curated by Videha, supplies precisely the correct set of avacchedakas. It is in this framework - and only in this framework - that Pt. Ramji Chaudhary and Acharya Ramlochan Sharan can be seen in their true proportions.

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**LESSON 070 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**

A Critical Study of the Works of

# RAMLOCHAN THAKUR

WHAT THE CANON LEFT OUT

A Parallel History of Mithila & Maithili Literature

Gajendra Thakur

# A Critical Study of the Works of
# RAMLOCHAN THAKUR

## I. BIOGRAPHICAL PROFILE

Ramlochan Thakur (रामलोचन ठाकुर) stands as one of the most distinguished and quietly luminous literary figures of modern Maithili literature. A poet, satirist, translator, editor, folklorist, and cultural activist, he devoted his life to the enrichment and preservation of the Maithili language and the cultural heritage of Mithila. He was, in the words of those who knew him, an ekanta sadhak — a solitary seeker — who worked far from the spotlight of public acclaim, shaping Maithili literature through decades of earnest and selfless effort.

### 1.1 Personal Details

**Full Name:** Ramlochan Thakur (रामलोचन ठाकुर)

**Pseudonyms:** Agradoot, Kumaresha Kashyap, Mujtaba Ali

**Birth:** 18 March 1949

**Death:** 25 March 2021, Kolkata

**Birthplace:** Babupali (Pali Mohan), Khajoli, Madhubani, Mithila

**Parents:** Father: Surjit Thakur; Mother: Sharda Devi

**Permanent Residence:** 2M, Chirag Apartments, 4, Italgacha Road, Kolkata

**Education:** Initial studies at Sanskrit Tol Pathshala; Matriculated (1963) from Kaluahi High School, Madhubani

### 1.2 Life Journey

Ramlochan Thakur was born in the village of Babupali in the Khajoli area of Madhubani district — the heartland of the Mithila region. His early education was rooted in classical Sanskrit learning in a traditional Tol Pathshala (Sanskrit school), which gave his later literary work a strong classical grounding while

remaining deeply alive to folk realities. After passing his matriculation examination in 1963, he moved to Kolkata at the age of just fifteen, driven by economic necessity and in search of livelihood.

Despite the pressures of a working life in the city, Thakur's attachment to Maithili language, literature, and Mithila's folk culture never wavered. Kolkata, which has historically been a major diaspora centre for Maithil communities, offered him both a community of fellow writers and an audience for his work. He engaged actively in the cultural and literary activities of the Maithil community in Kolkata throughout his life, while simultaneously contributing to Maithili periodicals and publishing houses rooted in Mithila.

He remained, until his death on 25 March 2021, a prolific yet self-effacing contributor to Maithili literature — equally at home writing original poetry, translating world literature into Maithili, compiling folk narratives, and editing literary collections.

## II. LITERARY WORKS AND PRODUCTIONS

Ramlochan Thakur's creative output spans across several decades and multiple genres — original poetry, satire, translation, folk literature compilation, criticism, and editorial work. His books are archived on the Videha First Maithili Fortnightly E-Journal (www.videha.co.in), the most significant online repository of Maithili literature. Below is a comprehensive listing of his works.

### 2.1 Original Poetry Collections

- Itihasahanta (इतिहासहंता) — 1977 [Original, Poetry]
- Mati-Panik Git (माटि-पानिक गीत) — 1985 [Original, Poetry]
- Desak Nam Chhalai Son Chiraiya (देशक नाम छलै सोन चिड़ैया) — 1986 [Original, Poetry]
- Apurva (अपूर्वा) — 1996 [Original, Poetry]
- Lakh Prasna Anuttarit (लाख प्रश्न अनुत्तरित) — 2003 [Original, Poetry]
- Yuddhabhumik Esgara Yoddha (युद्धभूमिक एसगर योद्धा) — 2017 [Original, Poetry] — Published in Videha

### 2.2 Satire and Prose

- Betal Katha (बेताल कथा) — 1981 [Original, Satire]
- Smritik Dhokaral Rang (स्मृतिक धोखरल रंग) — 2004 [Original, Essays / Memoir]
- Riharsal (रिहर्सल) — [Original, prose/play-related]

### 2.3 Translations (Anuvad)

- Pratidhvani (प्रतिध्वनि) — 1982 [Translation, Poetry] — verse translations into Maithili
- Jadugara (जादूगर) — 1982 [Translation, Drama / Natak]
- Phans (फाँस) — 1997 [Translation, Drama / Natak]
- Ja Sakai Chhi Kintu Kiye Jao (जा सकै छी किन्तु कियै जाउ) — 1999 [Translation, Poetry] — Awarded Bhasha-Bharati Samman by CIIL (2003–04)

### 2.4 Folk Literature and Editorial Work

- Maithili Lokakatha (मैथिली लोककथा) — 1983 (Compilation-Edition; reprinted 2006) [Folk Tales]
- Ajuk Kavita (आजुक कविता) — 1984 [Edited, Poetry Anthology]
- Kavipati Vidyapati Matiman (कविपति विद्यापति मतिमान) — 2000 [Co-edited, Critical Essays on Vidyapati]

### 2.5 Contributions Documented in Videha

According to the Videha archive (www.videha.co.in), Ramlochan Thakur's contributions are documented extensively, including in Videha-Sadeha 24 (the parallel anthology of the finest Maithili prose and verse), where a critical reading of his poetry titled 'Ramlochan Thakuraka Kavita Padhait' (रामलोचन ठाकुरक कविता पढ़ैत, pp. 327–341) appears. His essay titled 'Desilay Bayanaka Bahane Ramlochan Thakur Prasang' (pp. 347–357) is also preserved in the Videha-Sadeha 24 volume. These texts, compiled by editor Gajendra Thakur, constitute key primary sources for the study of his literary achievement.

### 2.6 Awards and Recognition

- Bhasha-Bharati Samman (2003–04) by CIIL (Central Institute of Indian Languages, Mysore) for translation
- Videha Samman 2012 (equivalent of a parallel Sahitya Akademi award) — translation prize — conferred by Videha Journal
- Prabodh Sahitya Samman — 2012 (shared with Chandrabhanu Singhji)
- Kiran Sahitya Samman — 2015 — by Kiran Maithili Sahitya Shodh Sansthan, Ujaan

## III. LITERARY ANALYSIS — INDIAN THEORETICAL FRAMEWORKS

The corpus of Ramlochan Thakur's writing lends itself richly to evaluation through multiple Indian critical traditions, from classical Sanskrit aesthetics to modern postcolonial and folk-critical approaches. Below, each major Indian theoretical framework is applied to his literature.

### 3.1 Rasa Theory (Bharatamuni's Natyashastra, c. 200 BCE – 200 CE)

Bharatamuni's doctrine of Rasa — the theory that art communicates through nine fundamental emotional essences (Shringara/love, Vira/heroism, Karuna/compassion, Adbhuta/wonder, Hasya/humour, Bhayanaka/terror, Bibhatsa/disgust, Raudra/fury, and Shanta/peace) — provides the most classical lens for evaluating Thakur's poetry.

His poetry collection Desak Nam Chhalai Son Chiraiya (1986), with its invocation of the golden-bird metaphor for a wounded nation, is saturated in Karuna Rasa (compassion) and Vira Rasa (heroic defiance). The title itself — 'the country's name was Golden Bird' — resonates with a profoundly elegiac sentiment about the betrayed promise of independent India, experienced through a Maithil migrant's consciousness. Similarly, Apurva (1996) exhibits Shringara Rasa not in its sensuous mode but in its sublimated, spiritual aspect — a longing for home, language, and cultural rootedness.

His satire collection Betal Katha (1981) operates primarily in the register of Hasya Rasa (comic/ironic) and Raudra Rasa (anger), deploying the folk-tale frame of Vikram and Baital to expose social hypocrisy, political corruption, and

cultural displacement. This dual-rasa combination — comedy masking fury — is a hallmark of the finest satire in the Maithili tradition.

In his translated poetry collection Pratidhvani (1982), the translator's task of capturing foreign emotional registers in Maithili requires what Sanskrit critics called Anukarna-rasa — the 'echo-rasa' — the sympathetic reverberation of another tradition's emotional world. Thakur's sensitivity to this challenge marks him as a translator-critic of considerable sophistication.

## 3.2 Dhvani Theory (Anandavardhana, 9th Century CE)

Anandavardhana's concept of Dhvani (resonance or suggestion) holds that the highest poetry operates on three levels of meaning: Abhidha (literal), Lakshana (secondary or metaphorical), and Vyanjana (suggestive or evocative). The best poetry, for Anandavardhana, is that which maximises the realm of the unspoken — where the suggested meaning (Dhvani) exceeds the stated.

Ramlochan Thakur's poetry exhibits masterful use of Dhvani, particularly in his treatment of the migrant experience. His poem 'Ja Sakai Chhi Kintu Kiye Jao' ('I can go, but why should I go') — whose title itself is the work's central Dhvani — stages the impossible predicament of the diaspora intellectual: the capacity to leave (literally: to go to the city, to assimilate, to abandon one's language) set against the moral impossibility of doing so. The suggestion reverberating beneath these lines is not merely personal but civilizational — the question of whether a marginalised language and its people should surrender to dominant linguistic cultures or resist.

Similarly, his folk poetry compilation Maithili Lokakatha resonates with Dhvani at the cultural level: the folk narrative is never only what it says but always also a map of a suppressed people's wisdom, fears, and cosmology. The act of compiling and publishing these tales is itself a form of Dhvani criticism — it makes the culture's suppressed 'suggestion' audible.

## 3.3 Auchitya (Propriety/Decorum) — Kshemendra, 11th Century CE

Kshemendra's theory of Auchitya holds that the highest standard of literary art lies in the appropriateness (auchitya) of every element — word, tone, genre, metre, imagery — to the subject being treated. Literature that achieves Auchitya is 'fitting' in the deepest sense: it puts nothing out of place.

Evaluated by this standard, Ramlochan Thakur's choice of genre for each subject is exemplary. He chooses satire (Betal Katha) to expose political

absurdity — a genre with deep precedent in the folk-satirical tradition of Mithila itself. He chooses lyric poetry to explore longing and displacement — and he uses folk-tale compilation when he wishes to honour the oral wisdom of rural Mithila without imposing literary artifice upon it. His translation work also exemplifies Auchitya: the choice of which foreign works to translate into Maithili reflects a careful sense of what the language needs and what it can absorb without distortion.

## 3.4 Vakrokti (Oblique Expression) — Kuntaka, 10th–11th Century CE

Kuntaka's theory of Vakrokti argues that literary language is fundamentally 'deviant' or 'oblique' — that is, literary power comes precisely from departure from ordinary speech. The deviance may be phonological, morphological, syntactic, or semantic; at every level, the literariness of a text consists in its productive deviation from the norm.

Ramlochan Thakur's satirical work exemplifies Vakrokti at the structural level. In Betal Katha, the ancient frame-narrative (Vikrama and Baital/Betal) is itself a form of Vakrokti — an oblique strategy for speaking about contemporary realities by displacing them into a legendary, fantastic register. This technique — using the old to speak the new, using fantasy to expose reality — is Vakrokti's most sophisticated literary-critical operation.

In his poetry, Thakur's Vakrokti often functions through understatement and laconic brevity. Where another poet might use ornate metaphor to describe suffering, Thakur characteristically uses syntactic compression and implication — saying less to mean more.

## 3.5 Alamkara Shastra (Doctrine of Figures of Speech)

Classical Sanskrit's Alamkara tradition (analysed by critics from Bhamaha in the 6th century to Mammata in the 11th) classifies the figures of speech (alamkaras) that constitute literary beauty: Rupaka (metaphor), Upama (simile), Utpreksha (fancy), Ananvaya (self-comparison), Yamaka (word-play), and many more.

Thakur's poetry is characterised by a selective and restrained use of alamkaras — unlike the ornamental excess that sometimes marks classical Sanskrit poetry. His most characteristic figure is Rupaka (sustained metaphor): the 'golden bird' for India, the 'solitary warrior of the battlefield' for the honest poet in a corrupt

literary market. These metaphors are not ornaments but load-bearing structures of meaning — the poem would collapse without them.

His translation work also required mastery of the equivalent between Sanskrit-derived Maithili alamkaras and the figures of foreign literary traditions. In Pratidhvani, this inter-cultural negotiation of figurative language is its most remarkable achievement.

## 3.6 Loka Sahitya (Folk Literature) Theory

The tradition of Loka Sahitya criticism in Indian scholarship — developed by scholars like Hazariprasad Dvivedi and extended to Maithili contexts by critics like Dr. Yogananda Jha (whose Loka-jivan o Loka-sahitya, 1986, is itself archived on Videha) — evaluates literature by its fidelity to and creative engagement with folk oral traditions.

Ramlochan Thakur's Maithili Lokakatha (1983, reprinted 2006) is a major contribution to this tradition. By systematically collecting, editing, and publishing Maithili folk tales, Thakur preserved a living archive of oral culture that might otherwise have been lost in the conditions of economic migration and cultural marginalisation that Maithil communities face. From a Loka Sahitya perspective, this act of collection is itself a critical act: it defines what belongs to the tradition, how it should be transmitted, and what its literary value is.

His own original poetry also draws heavily on folk imagery: the son chiraiya (golden bird), the imagery of mati-pani (soil and water), and the domestic and agricultural imagery of rural Mithila — all these signal a poet deeply formed by the folk imaginary even as he speaks within the conventions of modern literary verse.

## 3.7 Dalit and Bahujan Aesthetics

Maithili literature has historically been shaped by Brahminical upper-caste values — the cultural world of the Maithil Brahmin and Kayastha communities. The emergence of Dalit and Bahujan criticism in Hindi and other Indian literatures since the 1990s provides a framework for asking how Ramlochan Thakur's writing situates itself with respect to caste.

Thakur, writing from a Kshatriya-Thakur background and from the position of a rural-to-urban migrant, occupies a complex social location. His poetry, which frequently addresses the experience of powerlessness, displacement, and the gap between official national narratives and lived realities, has resonances with

the emerging Bahujan literary sensibility even if it does not explicitly invoke Ambedkarite political vocabulary. His satire Betal Katha can productively be read as a critique of the social hierarchies and ruling-class hypocrisies of Maithil society — including caste discrimination — though coded in the folk-satirical mode rather than direct political statement.

### 3.8 Stri-Vimarsha (Feminist Criticism in Indian Contexts)

Indian feminist literary criticism — developed by scholars like Susie Tharu, K. Lalita, and Madhu Kishwar, and extended to Maithili literature by figures associated with the Stri Kona section of Videha — offers a framework for evaluating how gender is constructed in Thakur's texts.

Thakur's poetry, with its consistent mourning of a lost cultural homeland, deserves feminist scrutiny regarding the figure of the 'motherland' (janmabhumi, mati-pani) as a feminised landscape. Such tropes — which are deep in Indian poetic tradition — risk equating women with passive territory to be mourned or possessed. At the same time, Thakur's folk tale compilations preserve stories in which women appear as active, cunning, and morally complex protagonists — the standard type of the clever wife, the determined daughter, the wise grandmother — which complicates any straightforward critique of patriarchal encoding. An honest feminist reading of his corpus must hold both tendencies in view.

## IV. LITERARY ANALYSIS — WESTERN THEORETICAL FRAMEWORKS

Western literary theory, from Aristotle to postcolonialism, offers additional analytical lenses through which Ramlochan Thakur's literature may be productively evaluated. Each of the following frameworks illuminates dimensions of his work that Indian classical theories may underemphasise.

### 4.1 Aristotelian Poetics and Mimesis

Aristotle's concept of mimesis — the idea that literature imitates reality not as it is but as it might or ought to be — provides a classical Western entry point into Thakur's poetic project. Aristotle distinguished between poetry (which deals with the universal) and history (which deals with the particular), arguing that the poet's task is to show not what happened but what kinds of things happen.

Thakur's poetry consistently operates at this level of the universal. The migrant Maithil poet in his verses is not a specific individual but a type — the disinherited intellectual, the custodian of a threatened culture, the citizen of a state that betrays its promises. His 1986 collection Desak Nam Chhalai Son Chiraiya, with its golden-bird allegory, achieves Aristotelian universality: the pain of postcolonial betrayal is rendered particular (Mithila, Maithili) while simultaneously aspiring to universal resonance (every culture that has seen its dreams deferred).

Thakur's satire Betal Katha can be read through Aristotle's discussion of comedy: the satirist shows people 'as worse than they are' in order to expose the gap between social pretension and moral reality. Betal Katha's deployment of folk-tale grotesquery to skewer contemporary politicians and social hypocrites is perfectly Aristotelian in this sense.

## 4.2 New Criticism — Close Reading and Organic Form

The American New Criticism of the mid-20th century (I. A. Richards, William Empson, Cleanth Brooks, Robert Penn Warren) emphasised close reading of the literary text as a self-contained, autonomous object, rich in irony, ambiguity, paradox, and tension. The New Critical approach asks: how does the poem achieve its unity? What tensions does it hold in productive suspension?

Applied to Thakur's poetry, a New Critical close reading of his title poem 'Ja Sakai Chhi Kintu Kiye Jao' reveals a structure built on paradox: the assertion of capability ('I can go') immediately undone by the assertion of ethical impossibility ('why should I go?'). The poem's irony is that the question mark — the simple interrogative — carries all the weight of cultural and political commitment. The 'why' is not a request for reasons but a refusal; the poet's question is itself his answer.

New Criticism also draws attention to Thakur's characteristic tension between folk diction and literary form. His best poems are exactly those in which the oral, earthy vocabulary of rural Mithila sits in productive tension with the structured, literary conventions of modern poetry — a tension between the mati-pani (soil-water) of folk speech and the artfully controlled form of the literary poem.

## 4.3 Marxist and Socio-Historical Criticism

Marxist literary criticism evaluates literature in relation to class conflict, material conditions, and ideological mystification. Critics in this tradition —

from Georg Lukács to Raymond Williams to Terry Eagleton — ask: what are the social contradictions this text responds to? Whose interests does it serve or challenge? How does it represent (or misrepresent) class relations?

Ramlochan Thakur's literature is deeply shaped by the social contradictions of post-independence Bihar and the experience of working-class migration. He left his village at fifteen to find work in Kolkata — a trajectory shared by millions of Maithil working-class migrants. His poetry speaks from within this experience of economic dispossession and cultural marginalisation without, however, becoming agit-prop.

His satire Betal Katha is the most overtly Marxist-readable work in his corpus: the exposed targets are political corruption, bureaucratic indifference, and the hypocrisy of the ruling class, rendered through the folk-satirical mode. But even his lyric poetry carries a Marxist-legible critique: the 'golden bird' that was once India's name, now lost, is a figure not only for cultural but also for economic betrayal — the unfulfilled promises of development, land reform, and social justice in post-independence Bihar.

Raymond Williams's concept of the 'structure of feeling' — the lived emotional experience of a historical moment that hasn't yet crystallised into formal ideology — is particularly apt for describing Thakur's contribution. His poetry captures the structure of feeling of a specific historical moment: the hopeful, wounded, resistant Maithil migrant consciousness of the 1970s–2000s.

## 4.4 Psychoanalytic Criticism (Freud, Lacan, Kristeva)

Psychoanalytic literary criticism — from Freud's analysis of the uncanny and the dreamwork, to Lacan's structuralist psychoanalysis, to Julia Kristeva's theory of abjection — focuses on the unconscious dimensions of literary texts: the repressed, the displaced, the sublimated.

Thakur's poetry is rich with the psychoanalytic themes of nostalgia and mourning — what Freud distinguished as two very different processes. In 'Lakh Prasna Anuttarit' (A Hundred Thousand Questions Unanswered, 2003), the sheer enumeration of questions — unanswered, because the answers would require the transformation of the world — suggests a melancholic structure rather than a mourning one. Melancholia, for Freud, is the state in which the lost object cannot be relinquished; the melancholic keeps asking questions to which no answer will suffice because the real question — why did I lose my home, my language, my world? — is unanswerable.

Julia Kristeva's concept of 'abjection' — the horrified rejection of what must be expelled (mother, body, origins) in order for the subject to constitute itself — illuminates the ambivalence in Thakur's relationship to Mithila's cultural world. The folk, the oral, the village, the mother tongue are simultaneously what his poetry most desires and what the metropolitan subject (the Kolkata migrant) is sociologically pressed to abject. His repeated return to these themes, in collection after collection across four decades, marks this as an unresolved psychic as much as cultural conflict.

## 4.5 Structuralism and Semiotics (Saussure, Lévi-Strauss, Barthes)

Structuralist criticism analyses texts as systems of signs, revealing the deep binary oppositions and narrative patterns that structure meaning. Roland Barthes's distinction between 'readerly' texts (lisible — which merely confirm reader expectations) and 'writerly' texts (scriptible — which demand active co-authorship from the reader) is particularly useful here.

Thakur's folk tale compilations (Maithili Lokakatha) operate primarily as readerly texts — they are designed to communicate folk wisdom clearly and accessibly to a broad audience. But his poetry is decidedly writerly: the compression, the unspoken assumptions, the layered allusions to Maithili literary and folk tradition all demand an active, co-authoring reader who brings to the text a knowledge of the tradition Thakur is drawing upon and transforming.

Lévi-Strauss's structural anthropology of myth — which reads folk narratives as unconscious mediations of binary contradictions (nature/culture, raw/cooked, male/female, life/death) — provides a framework for reading Thakur's Maithili Lokakatha not merely as entertainment but as a systematic cultural logic. Each folk tale mediates a contradiction in Mithila's social organisation; the collection as a whole maps the cultural unconscious of the region.

## 4.6 Post-Structuralism and Deconstruction (Derrida, de Man)

Deconstructive criticism, following Jacques Derrida, attends to the instabilities and contradictions within texts — the moments where a text undoes its own apparent claims, where the binary oppositions on which it rests are revealed as unstable. Paul de Man's emphasis on the 'rhetoric of blindness and insight' —

the idea that critics and writers are often most revealing where they think they are most in control — is equally pertinent.

A deconstructive reading of Thakur's poetry reveals productive instabilities in his central figures. The 'golden bird' of Desak Nam Chhalai Son Chiraiya is a figure for lost national promise — but the deconstruction asks: was the nation ever a golden bird, or was this always a myth? The poem mourns a loss, but a deconstructive reading asks whether the origin being mourned is itself a retrospective construction, a story we tell ourselves about a purity that never existed.

Similarly, the satire Betal Katha's implicit claim to moral authority — the satirist speaks truth to power — is deconstructively complicated by the folk-tale form itself, which always contains a trickster logic: who is really tricking whom? The Betal (Baital) of the folk original always wins; in Thakur's satire, the question of who has the last laugh is productively unresolved.

## 4.7 Postcolonial Theory (Said, Spivak, Bhabha)

Postcolonial criticism — as developed by Edward Said (Orientalism), Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak (Can the Subaltern Speak?), and Homi Bhabha (The Location of Culture) — offers perhaps the most illuminating framework for Ramlochan Thakur's entire literary project.

Said's concept of Orientalism — the West's construction of the 'East' as exotic, passive, and Other — finds its internal analogue in the relationship between Hindi and Maithili: Hindi, backed by state power and institutional resources, has historically 'Orientalised' Maithili as a rustic dialect, a minor tongue, the speech of a backwards region. Thakur's entire career is an implicit refusal of this Orientalisation — a sustained assertion that Maithili is a language with its own literary tradition, its own aesthetic standards, its own value.

Spivak's question 'Can the subaltern speak?' resonates acutely with Thakur's folk literature work. The Maithil folk — the landless labourers, the women, the lower-caste communities whose stories populate Maithili folk narrative — are subalterns in Spivak's sense: those whose speech is structurally inaudible within dominant institutional frameworks. Thakur's collection and publication of Maithili folk tales is an attempt to create conditions under which the subaltern's voice can be heard — though Spivak's caution remains: the very act of collection, editing, and literary publication transforms and partly domesticates the subaltern voice it seeks to rescue.

Homi Bhabha's concept of 'hybridity' and the 'third space' — the creative, unstable space between cultures where new identities are forged — captures the cultural location of Thakur's entire enterprise. Writing Maithili poetry in Kolkata, translating world literature into Maithili, using Sanskrit classical forms and folk oral forms simultaneously — all of this positions Thakur squarely in Bhabha's third space, a location of productive cultural negotiation and creative destabilisation.

## 4.8 Reception Theory and Reader-Response Criticism (Jauss, Iser)

Reception theory — as formulated by Hans Robert Jauss and Wolfgang Iser of the Constance School — shifts critical attention from the text and its author to the reader and the process of reading. Jauss's concept of the 'horizon of expectations' describes the set of literary, cultural, and generic conventions that a reader brings to a text, against which the text confirms or transforms their expectations.

The 'horizon of expectations' of Thakur's ideal reader is quite specific: someone who knows the Maithili literary tradition from Vidyapati onward, who is acquainted with the cultural geography of Mithila, who has some familiarity with the diasporic Maithil experience, and who can bring to bear both classical Sanskrit aesthetic categories and awareness of contemporary Indian political realities. This is a relatively small but critically important readership — the community of Maithili literary intellectuals — and Thakur's poetry is calibrated precisely for this community.

Iser's concept of the 'implied reader' — the ideal reader the text constructs through its own strategies — reveals that Thakur's poetry implies a reader who is simultaneously insider and outsider: someone who knows Mithila deeply enough to feel its loss but who is also, like the poet, living in the condition of diaspora and displacement.

## 4.9 Narratology (Genette, Propp)

Vladimir Propp's morphology of the folktale — which identifies thirty-one narrative functions and seven character types common to Russian (and, scholars have argued, universal) folk narratives — provides a structural framework for evaluating Thakur's Maithili Lokakatha. Propp's analysis suggests that folk tales operate through a limited set of narrative building

blocks, universally shared, which take on specific cultural coloration in different traditions.

Thakur's collected tales confirm Propp's morphology while also revealing the specific inflections of Maithili folk narrative: the particular role of the clever wife (the Maithili Sautan Katha type), the specificity of Mithila's agricultural and social world in the tales' settings, and the cultural logic of Maithil kinship structures in the tales' conflict resolutions.

Genette's narratological concepts — focalization, narrative voice, temporal ordering — are applicable to Thakur's poetry as much as his prose and folk compilations. His poems characteristically use a first-person lyric subject whose focalization is carefully managed: the 'I' of his poetry is simultaneously personal and representative, individual and collective.

### 4.10 Ecocriticism

Ecocriticism — the study of the relationship between literature and the natural environment — has emerged as a major critical school since the 1990s (Lawrence Buell, Greg Garrard, Rob Nixon). Nixon's concept of 'slow violence' — the gradual, invisible forms of environmental destruction that disproportionately affect the poor — is particularly relevant.

Thakur's poetry of Mithila, with its insistent imagery of mati-pani (soil and water), son chiraiya (golden bird), and the specific ecological landscape of the Gangetic plain and its rivers, is an ecocritical text before ecocriticism had a name. The 'golden bird' that the country once was is also an ecological figure — a land of fertile rivers, abundant wildlife, and rich agricultural life that has been despoiled by environmental degradation, flood mismanagement, and developmental neglect.

Nixon's 'slow violence' maps perfectly onto the ecological situation of Mithila: the annual floods, the gradual erosion of riparian land, the disappearing biodiversity of the floodplains — these are the slow violences that Thakur's poetry registers in the mode of lyric mourning.

## V. SYNTHESIS: THAKUR'S PLACE IN MAITHILI AND INDIAN LITERATURE

When the multiple theoretical lenses applied above are brought together, a coherent portrait of Ramlochan Thakur's literary achievement emerges. He is,

first and last, a poet of cultural survival — of what it means to carry a threatened language, a wounded land, and a displaced community's dignity across decades of marginalisation. His poetry is simultaneously classical and modern: classical in its grounding in Sanskrit Rasa theory and folk oral tradition, modern in its engagement with postcolonial realities and its formally restrained, imagistic sensibility.

His translation work is a form of cultural activism — each translation of a foreign work into Maithili is an assertion that Maithili can bear the weight of world literature, that the language is capacious enough to hold Brecht's drama or another tradition's lyric. The Bhasha-Bharati Samman he received from CIIL for this translation work is an institutional recognition of what is essentially a postcolonial literary-political act.

His folk literature compilations are an act of ethnographic preservation and cultural memory — closer, in their function, to Walter Benjamin's 'collector' (who rescues objects from the flow of historical destruction) than to any conventional academic folklorist. What Thakur collected, he gave back — not to a museum but to the living community of Maithili readers.

The Videha archive's preservation of his works — alongside the finest writers in the Maithili tradition from Vidyapati to the present day — situates him within a long literary lineage that he served faithfully. The critical reading of his poetry published in Videha-Sadeha 24 (pp. 327–341) confirms that his peers recognised the depth and distinctiveness of his contribution.

He died on 25 March 2021, in Kolkata — the city that had received him as a fifteen-year-old migrant six decades earlier. He died as he had lived: an ekanta sadhak, a solitary seeker, whose life's work was to keep Mithila's literary light burning in conditions of profound institutional neglect and cultural threat.

## VI. CONCLUSION

Ramlochan Thakur's literary corpus — spanning original poetry, satire, translation, folk compilation, and critical editorial work across more than four decades — constitutes a significant and underappreciated contribution to modern Indian literature. Evaluated through the full spectrum of Indian and Western literary theories, his work demonstrates extraordinary breadth and depth: it engages simultaneously with the classical aesthetics of Rasa and Dhvani, with the social realities of class and caste oppression, with the

postcolonial predicament of a minority language community, and with the universal human experience of loss, resistance, and hope.

His deployment of folk forms — the Betal Katha frame, the lok-katha tradition, the mati-pani imagery — within modern literary conventions creates a productive hybridity (in Bhabha's sense) that is formally distinctive. His commitment to translation as cultural activism, rewarded by the CIIL's Bhasha-Bharati Samman, represents the highest form of literary-political engagement: the act of saying, in one's own language, that the world's literature belongs to everyone.

The preservation of his works on the Videha platform — the first and most comprehensive Maithili digital literary archive — ensures that Ramlochan Thakur's voice will continue to reach readers long after his physical death. The Videha archive is itself a realisation of his life's project: that Maithili literature, properly preserved and made accessible, can endure.

A comprehensive academic study of his complete works — including close readings of individual poems, comparative analysis of his translations, and ethnographic evaluation of his folk collections — remains a desideratum of Maithili literary scholarship. This report is offered as a contribution to that larger project.

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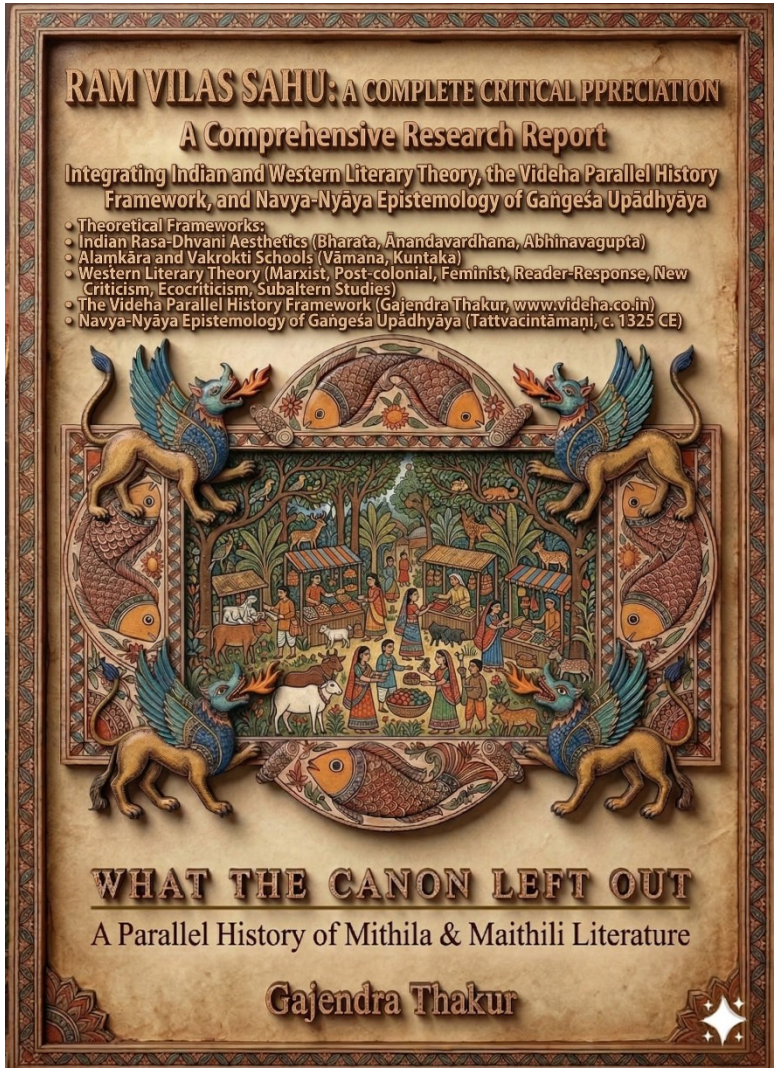
## LESSON 071 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY



# RAM VILAS SAHU: A COMPLETE CRITICAL APPRECIATION

## A Comprehensive Research Report Integrating Indian and Western Literary Theory, the Videha Parallel History Framework, and Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya

**Theoretical Frameworks:** - Indian Rasa-Dhvani Aesthetics (Bharata, Ānandavardhana, Abhinavagupta) - Alaṃkāra and Vakrokti Schools (Vāmana, Kuntaka) - Western Literary Theory (Marxist, Post-colonial, Feminist, Reader-Response, New Criticism, Ecocriticism, Subaltern Studies) - The Videha Parallel History Framework (Gajendra Thakur, www.videha.co.in) - Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (*Tattvacintāmaṇi*, c. 1325 CE)

## PART I: BIOGRAPHY, IDENTITY, AND INSTITUTIONAL CONTEXT

### *1.1 Life and Formation*

Ram Vilas Sahu (राम विलास साहु / रामविलास साहु), born **1 January 1957**, is among the most significant contemporary Maithili writers from what the Videha Parallel History framework identifies as the subaltern and backward-caste democratic tradition. His village is **Laxminiyā** (लक्ष्मीनियाँ), Post: Jainā, Via: Narahiyā, P.S. Laukahī, District: **Madhubani**, Bihar, Pin: 847108. He is contactable at +91 99558 02522.

The autobiographical preface to the second edition of *Rathak Cakkā Ulait Cale Bāṭ* (2024) is one of the most candid and revealing self-portraits in contemporary Maithili literature. In it, Sahu describes his intellectual formation with characteristic honesty: unable to secure government employment despite education, he turned to private teaching (*ṭyūśan*) and subsequently co-founded "Gyān Bhāratī Public School" in Nirmali with colleagues, running it for fourteen years. Meanwhile, residing in the village, he turned to agriculture and began reading literary works — and through this combination of agrarian rootedness and literary apprenticeship, his writing career emerged.

The pivotal moment came around 2004, when he met **Umesh Mandal** — sub-editor of Videha and son of the great Maithili novelist Jagdish Prasad Mandal. Umesh Mandal showed Sahu his father's writings, fostering conversation between the younger and older writer. Shortly thereafter, Umesh Mandal introduced Sahu to **Gajendra Thakur**, editor of Videha. Thakur's encouragement proved decisive: Sahu began writing, and Thakur facilitated the publication of his first book, *Rathak Cakkā Ulait Cale Bāṭ*, through Shruti Prakashan, Delhi, in 2013. He acknowledges both Jagdish Prasad Mandal (as mentor) and Gajendra Thakur (as literary patron and enabler) as the two figures most responsible for his emergence as a writer.

### *1.2 The Sahu Community and Subaltern Writing*

The surname "Sahu" (साहु) identifies Ram Vilas Sahu as belonging to the Sahu caste — a trading and shopkeeping community classified as Other Backward Class (OBC) in Bihar's social hierarchy. His emergence as a significant Maithili writer represents a challenge to the historically upper-caste (predominantly Maithil Brahmin) dominance of Maithili literary institutions. The *Outlook India* interview with Maithili literary critic Ashok explicitly places "Ram Vilas Sahu" alongside Jagdish Prasad Mandal and Umesh Mandal as writers "from backward castes [who] have come [and] integrated a larger community with Maithili literature through their works and activities."

This social positioning — a writer from an OBC community, educated but economically constrained, rooted in a village near Nirmali-Supaul rather than in the literary capitals of Darbhanga or Delhi — defines both the content and the form of Sahu's writing. His poetry consistently speaks for and from the perspective of farmers, labourers, the rural poor, women suffering under dowry violence, and Dalit communities. His short stories expose the structural corruption of panchayat governance, the inequities of caste-based social ceremony, and the absurdities of a schooling system that rewards abandonment of one's rural community.

### *1.3 The Videha Connection and Institutional Role*

The connection to Videha is not merely a publication relationship: Sahu is listed in the Videha masthead (as accessible through www.videha.co.in) as one of its editorial associates. His books are published by Pallavi Prakashan, Nirmali — the same distributor network (Pallavi Distributors, Ward 6, Nirmali, Supaul) that circulates the Munnaji, Vineet Utpal, and other Videha-circle

books. This network constitutes the counter-canonical publishing infrastructure of the Maithili Parallel tradition.

### *1.4 Published Works: Complete Inventory*

Based on the autobiographical preface of *Rathak Cakkā* (2nd ed., 2024), Sahu's published works include:

8. *Rathak Cakkā Ulait Cale Bāṭ* — Poetry, Tanka, Haiku (2013, 1st ed.; 2024, 2nd ed.)
9. *Kosīk Kaṭer* (Koshi's Bank) — Prose/Story collection
10. *Gāmak Sukh* (Village Happiness) — Prose/Story collection
11. *Manek Mail* (Manak Mail) — Narrative collection
12. *Aṅkur* (Sprout/Seedling) — Story collection (2016)
13. *Dūdhbechnī* (The Milk-seller woman) — Short Story collection (2018)
14. *Aṃśumān* — Collection
15. *Nehdān* — Collection
16. *Karm Binu Jag Sunnā* (Without Work the World is Empty) — Second poetry/tanka collection
17. *Skūlak Khicṛī* (The School's Khichri) — Seed stories / Vihinikathā

## PART II: PRIMARY WORKS — SYSTEMATIC ANALYSIS

### *2.1 Rathak Cakkā Ulait Cale Bāṭ (The Wheel of the Chariot Turns Backward to Make its Way, 2013/2024)*

**Title semantics:** The title is a compressed philosophical-political statement. *Rathak cakkā* (the wheel of the chariot) evokes simultaneously the *dharmacakra* (Wheel of Dharma, the Buddhist image of cosmic order) and the *Bhagavad Gīta's* chariot (Arjuna's chariot of moral crisis). *Ulait* (turned backward/reversed/upside down) suggests inversion, revolutionary disruption, the world turned the wrong way around. *Cale bāṭ* (making its path/going forward) completes the paradox: progress through reversal. The title thus announces a fundamentally radical poetics: the established order must be overturned for true forward movement to begin.

Gajendra Thakur's preface (dated 18 May 2012) — included in the second edition — is an important critical document. Thakur identifies the following key characteristics of Sahu's poetry:

**Nature poetry and its ecological precision:** Thakur quotes a tanka that captures the beauty of the Sāvan (monsoon) rains with precise natural observation: *"Sāvan māsa / jalak dhun paṛai / āsamānsaṃ / baiṃgak bābā bajai / khantā dharā bharai"* — "In the month of Savan / the sound of water falls / from the sky / the Father of Frogs calls / the furrow-earth fills." Thakur compares this to Bashō and notes the profound integration of human agricultural activity (the khantā, or furrow) with the natural monsoon cycle.

**Haiku and tanka as formal precision:** Sahu is identified as one of the pioneers of haiku and tanka writing in Maithili. The collection contains both forms alongside regular poems and songs (*gīt*).

**Social poetry:** The collection addresses caste (*Dom ki āgi* — the Dom's Fire), agrarian poverty, inflation (*mahagāī*), the farmer's suffering (*droughts*, floods, the Koshi floods specifically), corruption in governance, dowry violence, and displacement.

**The table of contents** (2024 edition) reveals the thematic architecture: *Mahagāī* (Inflation), *Koilī Kuhkai Āmak Ḍārr* (The Cuckoo sings on the mango branch), *Prītak Gīt* (Song of Love), *Gañjan* (Abuse/Persecution), *Kammak Phal* (The fruit of work), *Premak Bānh* (The bond of love), *Jībait Calū* (Keep living), *Jabsal Gīt* (An unsatisfied/unresolved song), *Jaṛait Dīp* (Lighting the lamp), *Gāmak Nārī* (The village woman), *Napiyāsal Dharatī* (The unquenched Earth), *Cintā-Citā* (Worry-Funeral Pyre), *Mātṛbhūmi* (Motherland), *Mitlāk Abhinandan* (Mithila's Welcome), *Ī Kī Kelauṃ Ahāṃ* (What did you do?), *Kekrā Saṃg Khelab Horī* (With whom will I play Holi?), *Gāe-Māe* (Cow-Mother), *Khetiharak Jinagī* (The Farmer's Life), *Gyānak Dīp* (The Lamp of Knowledge), *Dukhāel Gaṃgā* (The Suffering Ganga), *Beṃgak Bariyātī* (The Frog's Wedding Party), *Balānak Bādh* (The Balan River's Embankment), *Pāninakbūnn* (Drops of Water), *Harāel Bhagavān* (The Lost God), *Jībale* (For living), *Caitābar Gīt* (Spring/Chaiti Song), *Caiti Gīt* (Chaiti Song), *Premak Bhūkhal* (Hungry for love), *Maṛuāk Mān* (The honour of millet/millet-eater), *Aramān* (Longing), *Bhārat Mātā* (Mother India), *Pardeshī* (The foreigner/migrant), *Manek Bāt Kī Kahab* (What will I tell of my heart's story), *Dhanrōpanī* (Rice transplanting), *Laphaṃgā* (The vagrant/rascal), *Berōzgārī* (Unemployment), *Rupaiyāk Ḍherī* (A pile of money), *Bhraṣṭācārī* (The corrupt one), *Āel Basant* (Spring has come), *Apan-Parāyā* (One's own vs. strangers), *Bāṭ Baṭohī* (The wayfarer), *Hāṭak Cāur Bāṭak Pānan* (The market's rice, the

road's betel), *Gyān Bāṃṭait Calū* (Keep distributing knowledge), *Premānak Paisā* (Love's money), *Kālak Pahrā* (Time's guard), *Nipiyāsal Man* (The unquenched mind), *Dahejak Khel* (The game of dowry), *Ghar Pardesh* (Home is abroad), *Gahumak Kaṭanī-Daonī* (Wheat harvest and threshing), *Biāh Kī Chī?* (What is marriage?), *Āzukā Dina* (Today's day), *Putra Kuputra* (Good son, bad son), *Kateka Dukh Kāṭab Hari He* (How much suffering shall I endure, O Hari), *Bāraho Māsa* (All twelve months), *Saṛak Bīc Nālā* (A gutter in the middle of the road), *Āṃkhi Rahito Ānhar* (Blind despite having eyes), *Bhāg Bharose* (On fate's mercy), *Phūl-Pattā* (Flower-leaf), *Bhabdā* (The Bhabda bird), *Bābā Bale Phaṃ Dārī* (Father's traps), *Kekrā Le Kānab* (For whom will I weep?), *Parivartan* (Change), *Māiyak Mamatā* (Mother's love), *Pardeshiyā Pāhun* (The migrant guest), *Dhartīk Sukh* (Earth's joy), *Sonak Rāti* (Golden night), *Lobhī Bhomhrā* (The greedy bumblebee), *Bhorak Kṣaṇ* (The morning moment), *Garībak Māna* (The poor person's honour), *Māe* (Mother), *Hamar Gāma Ghar* (My village-home), *Anagalagī* (The unrelenting/the one who won't let go), *Kālī Maiyāk Gīt* (Song of Kali Maa), *Hamar Bikharal Samāj* (My fragmented society), *Ciṛai Cunamunnī* (Little bird), *Māik Lāl* (Mother's beloved son), *Ke Garīb* (Who is poor?), *Naināk Khel* (The game of eyes), *Nīṃdiyā Bairī Bhal Pahunā* (Sleep has become an enemy-guest), *Pāgal Premī* (The mad lover), *Kosīme Samāel Jinagī* (Life swallowed by the Koshi) + Haiku/Tanka section (pages 98-113).

### *2.2 Karm Binu Jag Sunnā (Without Work the World is Empty — Second Poetry Collection)*

This collection of poems and tanka takes its title from its opening poem, a systematic catalogue of cosmological dependencies expressed through absence (*binā/binu* = without):

*"Sūj binu akās sunnā / bijurī binu bādal sunnā / jīv binu dharatī sunnā / koyal binu baṛgiyā sunnā / phūl binu phulvārī sunnā / sher binu van sunnā / nayan binu jag sunnā / prāṇ binu deh sunnā / rājā binu rājya sunnā / satya binu nyāy sunnā / svara binu saṃgīt sunnā / nārī binu samāj sunnā / dūdh binu bhojan sunnā / pāni binu nadī sunnā / dev binu mandir sunnā / dayā binu dharm sunnā / prem binu bhakti sunnā / karm binu jag sunnā"*

The poem lists seventeen cosmic dependencies — sun-sky, lightning-cloud, life-earth, cuckoo-grove, flower-garden, lion-forest, eye-world, soul-body, king-kingdom, truth-justice, melody-music, woman-society, milk-food, water-river, deity-temple, compassion-religion, love-devotion — before arriving at its climactic eighteenth: "Without work the world is empty." This encyclopaedic

poem of absence is simultaneously a cosmological meditation and a labour manifesto: work is the ground condition of all value.

Key poems in this collection, as fully extracted, include:

**Raudī** (Drought): One of Sahu's most powerful agrarian protest poems, describing the farmer's destitution during a drought — "Māthpar hāth dhene / khetiharak āṃkhisaṃ giral nora" (With hand on head / tears fell from the farmer's eyes). The poem moves through the destruction of crops, the uselessness of prayers, the failure of government, and concludes with the bitter irony that "Māṃgai chhai pāni tā / ḍījalak anudan bhaiṭai chhai" (He asks for water, he gets diesel subsidies).

**Sisamar Ker Phūl** (The Silk-cotton Flower): An allegorical poem about a parrot (*sugā*) seduced by the brilliant red flowers of the silk-cotton tree (*sisamar/sembal*) rather than focusing on fruiting trees. The parrot, distracted by appearance, ends up hungry. The poem explicitly draws the moral: "Paraiṃg dekhi nai lobhāu / pak māyā jāl phaṃsi / bhukhe tejab prāṇ" (Don't be seduced by colour / caught in the web of illusion / you'll die of hunger). This is a classic kāvya-style poem using animal allegory (*dṛṣṭāntā*) in the manner of the Pañcatantra.

**Olympic**: A sharp political satire on the misallocation of national resources toward prestige projects while rural poverty continues: "Jantāk vikeṭ gir gael / deśak paiyā khel-khelame" (The people's wicket has fallen / the nation's money spent on games). "Gāme berosgārī baṛhi gael / āzād deśame ke āzād bhaeal" (Unemployment has grown in the village / in the free country who has become free).

**Megḥak Bariyātī** (The Cloud's Wedding Procession): A lyrical celebration of the monsoon as a bridal procession — "Gami bhagbale / megḥak bariyātī śurū bhaeal" (To defeat heat / the cloud's wedding procession began). This poem shows Sahu's capacity for celebratory lyricism alongside his protest poetry — the two modes coexist without contradiction.

**Pusk Rāti** (The Winter Night): A harrowing depiction of extreme poverty in winter — "Phuisak ghar khopaṛī san / kenā bitāeb puśak rāti" (A house of dried grass like a hut / how shall I spend the winter night). The poem accumulates images of destitution: the cloth of straw, the blanket of coarse fabric, the frozen children — and ends with the communal question "Ke karat garībak kalyāṇ" (Who will do the welfare of the poor).

**Kenā Kahab Bhārat Mahān** (How Shall I Call India Great): A sustained critique of post-independence failure to deliver on the promises of freedom: "Jo deśak lel tyāg karae / okre jiangī narak san banel-e" (Those who sacrificed for

the country / their lives have become like hell). The poem invokes the freedom fighter who gave his life, the farmer who laboured, the soldier — all betrayed by the postcolonial state.

**Caubaṭiyāpar Izzati Luṭāe** (Honour is looted at the crossroads): On gender violence in public spaces.

**Āgie Āgie** (Fire everywhere): "Sagaro lagal chhai āgie āgi / bhāgi paṛā ke tae jāeb" (Everywhere fire burns / where will we flee). An enumeration of social fires: the fire of dowry, the fire of inflation, the fire of corruption, the fire of petrol prices — all consuming the people.

**Dū Najar** (Two Eyes/Double Standard): A poem on caste discrimination and hypocrisy: "Panv panv sam paṛihi / sab manukh manukhe chī" (We stand on equal ground / all human beings are human) — yet social reality divides them by caste and class. The poem addresses untouchability directly: "Kaue chubaī chī" (Why do we practice untouchability?).

**Miithilāk Piyās** (Mithila's Thirst): On the state of Maithili language and the failure of internal unity among Maithili-speakers: "Jādhar mithlāme maithilī / sab janak bhāṣā nai banatak / tādhar nai mithlāk piyās mujhatak" (So long as Maithili / is not the language of all people in Mithila / Mithila's thirst will not be quenched).

**Tanka Section:** The tanka (31-syllable Japanese-derived form, five lines of 5-7-5-7-7 syllables) covers themes of knowledge-sharing, communal harmony, anti-caste solidarity, ecological awareness, and democratic aspiration. A representative tanka: *"Anpaṛhakeṃ / dī akṣarak bodh / pothi paṛhi kai / gyānī bani gyānakeṃ / ghar-ghar bāṃṭatak"* (Give literacy to the illiterate / reading books / becoming educated / distribute knowledge from house to house).

### *2.3 Dūdhbechnī (The Milk-seller Woman, 2018)*

**Publication:** Pallavi Prakashan, Berma/Nirmali. ISBN: 978-93-87675-71-1. Price Rs. 200/-. Publisher: Shruti Prakashan address used (20, Bikteri Shah Road, Kolkata-700007).

This collection of short stories (*laghu kathā*) is named after its title story about a milk-selling woman — a figure emblematic of the gendered labour economy of Mithila's agrarian world. The preface by Sahu locates the collection's origins in his acute observation of village social life: the characters who populate these stories are drawn from the ecology of Madhubani and Supaul districts.

**Table of Contents:** 1. *Bāre Bāj* (Good/Resonant Sound — page 9) 2. *Naurōī Nōcā* (Nine Notches — page 14) 3. *Tūl Bāṛ Jōl* (The weight of pain — page 26) 4. *Siphal Bāṛ* (Fruitful — page 34) 5. *U-Ucā Nōs De Moc Caur Nōc Piye Cāurā Nōcy* (Extended social drama — page 43) 6. *Maṛu Śikṣā* (Education in crisis — page 50) 7. *Deī Dem Rā Nōs Le Sib Manm Dūdh Cecnī* (page 55) 8. *Rōcī Nōs Ā* (The Doodhbechnee story — page 64) 9. *Dūdhbechnī* (page 79) 10. *Bō Ārōc Nōs Tūl Rāy* (page 84) 11. *Apnaṃd Rā* (page 93) 12. *E Nait Nōd* (page 101)

### *2.4 Skūlak Khicṛī (The School's Khichri) — Vihinikathā Collection*

This collection of seed stories (*vihinikathā*) and short stories (*laghu kathā*) is one of Sahu's most formally accomplished works, directly engaging with the micro-fiction tradition that the Videha movement has championed. The title story — "Skūlak Khicṛī" (The School's Khichri) — opens with an irate parent storming into a school to berate the headmaster about the midday meal scheme (*khicṛī*). The headmaster's gentle response — that the khichri scheme, unlike private schools, keeps children rooted in their community and values rather than alienating them from family, village, and mother tongue — is a microcosm of the collection's social philosophy.

Key stories: - **"Cor-Sipāhī"** (Thief-Policeman): A winter-night encounter between a fleeing thief and a constable on patrol. The thief tricks the constable by asking permission to light a biri from the nearby fire, prompting the constable to say "Stay here, I'll go light it" — a comic reversal that illuminates the absurdity of the policing relationship. - **"Imāndārīk Pāṭh"** (The lesson of honesty): A dialogue between two village boys on why students from the village school prefer the city school — city schools teach "the lesson of employment" while village schools teach "the lesson of honesty." The ironic twist reveals that "honesty" means staying in the village to farm, while "employment" means alienation from family and land. - **"Bauā Bājal"** (The child spoke): A literate-but-unemployed man teaching neighbourhood children, asked by a child: "Why do people study so hard? Whether you study or not, you die one day." The teacher's philosophic answer is undercut by the child's final response: "I won't be a poet or writer — they earn nothing; the paper said they get awards only after death." - **"Ghūshā Ghar Mukhiyājī"** (The Corrupt Headman): An extended and devastating exposé of panchayat corruption through the Indira Awas Yojana (housing scheme) — every person who receives housing must pay a bribe. Old Budhni refuses: "If I build a house with bribe money, what kind of house will I live in?" Her defiance against the mukhiya is the seed story's moral centre. - **"Jātik Bhōj"** (The feast of caste): A

wedding feast to which the lower-caste workers who prepared everything — the Dom, the Kumhar, the Mali, the fishermen — are not invited to eat. The story makes the caste hypocrisy visible through the simple observation that those whose labour makes the feast are excluded from it. - **“Śikṣāk Mahat”** (The importance of education): A story of agrarian debt, land loss, and the decision of a poor family (Jībach and Radhiyā) to educate their children at all costs — because illiteracy allowed the zamindar to forge fingerprint signatures on documents and steal their land. The story directly connects education to property rights and justice. - **“Ī Chī Hamr Majbūrī”** (This is my compulsion): A story of a *pravacankartā* (religious preacher) who publicly preaches equality of all humans but privately admits: “If I say in the sermon what you’re asking, the establishment won’t let me live. This is my compulsion.” - **“Bāl-Bodh”** (The children’s understanding): A Dickensian story of a desperate poor man (Dukhilāl) forced to pledge his two small sons (Budhan and Bechan, aged 8-10) as child labourers to clear a debt. The landowner’s willingness to accept child labour and the children’s guileless response (“We don’t distinguish between our work and others’ work — we’ll work”) creates a devastating indictment of bonded child labour. - **“Abisavās”** (Distrust/Betrayal): About a dowry negotiation that collapses: an engineer-groom’s family demands the final instalment before the wedding; the bride (Citrā) refuses to marry a man whose family cannot trust hers; she walks out, locks the groom in a room, and demands full restitution — a story of female agency against dowry extortion. - **“Ḍomak Āgi”** (The Dom’s Fire): A story set at a funeral where the entire village waits from morning to afternoon for “Baukaū Dom” to arrive and sell the fire for the pyre — because upper-caste tradition requires purchasing fire from the Dom community. The story uses this ritual delay to expose the constitutive contradiction of caste: the Dom is untouchable in life but indispensable in death. The internal monologue of Sītarām Dās — reflecting on Mithila’s social order — is the story’s moral centre. - **“Vargak Sukh”** (Class/Heaven’s Joy): A story about Baukaū, a Dom living on the Koshi riverbank, whose community is flooded out. In the deepest winter poverty, he and his family forage for grain and a tortoise, cook it with monsoon-grown rice, and eat a simple feast together. The husband says: “This is paradise’s joy. Even kings and maharajas don’t get this in their decorated palaces.” The story is a celebration of subaltern resilience and the politics of sufficiency. - **“Gaṃgā Nahāeb”** (Taking a Ganga bath): A story of a group of village women going to bathe in the Ganga at Simriya Ghat (Katihar) — and the satirical reflection on the commodification of religious merit when the river itself is polluted and what they’re really bathing in is “everyone’s sins.”

### *2.5 Ankur and Manak Mail*

*Aṅkur* (Sprout) is published in 2016 by Pallavi Prakashan and co-edited by Umesh Mandal — itself a document of the collaborative Videha network. *Mānak Mail* (Standard/Benchmark Letter/Train) appears to be a longer narrative or collection published in 2018 (separately from *Dūdhbechnī*).

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## PART III: CRITICAL APPRECIATION THROUGH MULTIPLE FRAMEWORKS

### *3.1 Indian Rasa-Dhvani Aesthetics*

#### 3.1.1 Dominant Rasas

Bharata's *Nāṭyaśāstra* identifies eight *sthāyibhāvas* (permanent emotions) that generate the eight rasas. Ram Vilas Sahu's work operates across several rasas simultaneously, but the dominant register is the dual complex of **karuṇa** (pathos/compassion) and **vīra** (heroism/courage), with strong admixture of **bībhatsa** (disgust at social injustice) and **hāsya** (satirical comedy).

**Karuṇa** is the rasa of suffering-witnessing — the emotional response to the sight of another's pain. Sahu's *Raudī* (Drought) is paradigmatic: the farmer's hand on his head (*māthpar hāth dhene*), the cracked earth, the scorched crops, the children who cannot eat — these are the *vibhāvas* (excitants) that generate karuṇa in the reader. The poem's refrain returns to the helplessness: "without water, every living being / daily surrenders its life-breath." The *anubhāva* (consequent manifestation) is the reader's urge to act — but the poem offers no resolution, holding the reader in productive discomfort.

**Vīra** (heroism) operates in poems like *Kenā Kahab Bhārat Mahān* (How Shall I Call India Great), where the poet's refusal to accept the dominant nationalist narrative — the insistence that true heroism was the farmer's daily sacrifice, not the politician's rhetoric — is itself an act of vīra. Similarly, the bride Citrā in "Abisavās" embodies vīra: her refusal to be sold, her assertion of self-respect, her counter-demand that all dowry be returned — all instantiate the heroic impulse within the domestic sphere.

**Hāsya** (comedy/satire) pervades the seed stories. "Cor-Sipāhī" (Thief-Policeman) generates *hāsya* through the reversal of the expected power relation: the weak (the old thief) outsmarts the strong (the young constable). "Skūlak Khicṛī" generates *hāsya* through the headmaster's ironic defense of the

midday meal scheme, exposing the corrupt system it serves even as he defends it. “Bouā Bājal” generates *hāsya* through the child’s devastating logic: why study when even the greatest writers die unrecognized?

### 3.1.2 Dhvani: The Soul of Sahu’s Poetry

Ānandavardhana’s *Dhvanyāloka* (c. 9th century CE) argues that poetry achieves its highest power through *vyañjanā* — suggestion, resonance, the meaning that vibrates beneath the expressed meaning. Sahu’s best poems consistently operate at this suggestive level.

The poem *Karm Binu Jag Sunnā* (Without work the world is empty) generates its dhvani through the structural principle of *abhāva* (absence): each line states a dependency through absence — “without X, Y is empty” — until the climactic “without work, the world is empty.” The expressed meaning (*vācyārtha*) is a simple observation about work’s centrality. The indicated meaning (*lakṣyārtha*) is a critique of privilege: those who don’t work are themselves “empty.” The suggested meaning (*vyañjanārtha*) is a fundamental statement about labour as the ground of all existence — a poetics of solidarity with the working class.

The title of the first collection, *Rathak Cakkā Ulait Cale Bāṭ*, operates at multiple dhvani levels simultaneously. The expressed meaning is simply “the chariot-wheel reversed goes forward.” The indicated meaning invokes *dharma-cakra* (wheel of dharma) and the *Bhagavad Gītā’s* chariot — tradition being reversed, or overturned. The suggested meaning is the deepest: genuine progress (*cale bāṭ* — making the path) requires the reversal (*ulait*) of the existing social order.

### 3.1.3 Vakrokti and Oblique Expression

Kuntaka’s *Vakroktijīvita* (c. 10th century CE) defines *vakrokti* as the mode of oblique, figurative expression that distinguishes poetry from mere statement. Sahu’s seed stories are exercises in vakrokti: they never state their critique directly but embody it in narrative form. “Ghūshā Ghar Mukhiyājī” does not say “panchayat corruption is wrong” — it shows Budhni refusing a bribe-house with the question: “If I build a house with bribe money, what kind of house will I live in?” The critique is embedded in the narrative act.

The poem *Sisamar Ker Phūl* (The Silk-cotton Flower) is a perfect example of *dṛṣṭānta vakrokti* (oblique expression through extended example): the parrot’s seduction by the red flowers of the silk-cotton tree is never directly glossed as a

political allegory, but the resonance with political leaders seduced by the "colourful" promises of power at the expense of substantive work (*karm*) is unmissable.

### *3.2 Western Literary Frameworks*

#### 3.2.1 Marxist and Materialist Criticism: Labour, Class, and Alienation

Karl Marx's concept of *alienated labour* — the estrangement of the worker from the product of his labour, from the act of production, from his species-being, and from other workers (*Economic and Philosophic Manuscripts of 1844*) — provides the deepest theoretical framework for reading Sahu's poetry. The poem *Karm Binu Jag Sunnā* is, in Marxist terms, a counter to alienation: it insists on the centrality of unalienated, purposeful, recognized labour as the foundation of all value.

The farmer in *Raudī* is alienated in the double sense: estranged from the fruits of his labour (drought destroys the crop) and from the political system that should support him (the government gives diesel subsidies when he needs water). Marx's formula — "the worker produces capital and capital produces the worker as worker" — is dramatized in Sahu's story *Bāl-Bodh*: the poor father (Dukhilāl) literally sells his children's labour to clear a debt, reproducing the conditions of his own exploitation.

György Lukács's concept of *reification* (the transformation of human relations into thing-like relations) illuminates the *Jātik Bhōj* (Caste Feast) story: the elaborate social organization of the wedding feast — who cooks, who serves, who eats — is a reified system in which the caste hierarchy operates as though it were a natural law rather than a contingent social arrangement. Sahu's story defamiliarizes this reification, making visible what ideology has naturalized.

Raymond Williams's *structures of feeling* (*Marxism and Literature*, 1977) — the pre-formalized affective dimensions of social experience — describes precisely what Sahu's stories capture: the way inflation, migration, drought, dowry violence, and Koshi flooding are not just political facts but lived emotional textures that literature can render before sociology has formalized them.

#### 3.2.2 Subaltern Studies and the Politics of Voice

Gayatri Spivak's foundational essay "Can the Subaltern Speak?" (1988) raises the question of whether the subaltern can speak within the dominant representational order, or whether her speech is always already appropriated,

distorted, or silenced. Ram Vilas Sahu's literary project is a direct response to this question: it insists that the subaltern *can* speak, provided the literary institution (Videha, Pallavi Prakashan, the counter-canonical network) creates the conditions for this speech.

Sahu's own story — an OBC man from a Madhubani village who found his literary voice through the Videha movement — is itself an example of the subaltern gaining conditions for speech. His fiction gives voice to farmers, migrant labourers, poor women, Dalit Dom communities, and malnourished children. The story "Ḍomak Āgi" is particularly significant: it makes the Dom community's position at once indispensable and despised — the only group that can "sell fire" for the funeral pyre, yet excluded from all social spaces of living — a condition of structural paradox that Spivak's framework describes precisely as the subaltern's constitutive double-bind.

The voice of Budhni in "Ghūshā Ghar Mukhiyājī" — her refusal of the corrupt mukhiya's offer, her simple moral clarity — is the subaltern speaking clearly and with authority. The story's power derives from the contrast between this moral clarity and the total material powerlessness of the speaker: Budhni has no institutional recourse, but she speaks the truth that others will not.

### 3.2.3 Feminist Criticism: Women's Bodies, Labour, and Agency

Multiple frameworks from feminist criticism apply to Sahu's work. Sandra Gilbert and Susan Gubar's concept of the *madwoman in the attic* — the repressed, silenced woman whose "madness" is the only form of protest available to her — is subverted in Sahu's fiction: his women are not mad but lucid, not passive but actively resistant.

The bride Citrā in "Abisavās" is the most striking example: she refuses marriage not through romantic sentiment but through political analysis ("if his family cannot trust mine, he cannot trust me; and a man who lets his father sell dignity can sell me too"). This is not madness but rigorous feminist reasoning. The story anticipates what Judith Butler (*Gender Trouble*, 1990) calls performative gender resistance: Citrā does not merely complain about the system but disrupts its performance — literally refusing to put on the *varmāla* (marriage garland) and locking the groom in a room.

The story of Radhiyā in "Śikṣāk Mahat" is equally significant: her decision to ensure her children's education despite extreme poverty is presented not as self-sacrifice (the conventional "good mother" narrative) but as political wisdom. She has already been exploited through illiteracy; her children's education is an act of class warfare by other means.

Karuṇā (compassion) for women's gendered labour appears throughout the poetry: *Gāmak Nārī* (The village woman), *Nārī binu samāj sunnā* (Without woman society is empty), *Māe* (Mother), *Māiyak Mamatā* (Mother's love) — all of these engage with the uncompensated labour of women as the foundation of household and community life.

### 3.2.4 Post-Colonial Theory: Language, Identity, and Mithila

Ngugi wa Thiong'o's argument in *Decolonizing the Mind* (1986) — that colonial languages internalize the colonized people's sense of their own inferiority, and that writing in one's mother tongue is an act of political decolonization — applies directly to Sahu's choice to write in Maithili. Maithili has been systematically misclassified as a dialect of Hindi by colonial and postcolonial governance, despite Grierson's and Chatterji's authoritative attestation of its linguistic independence. T.K. Oomen's sociological observation (quoted in the Videha Parallel History) that Maithili is treated as a Hindi dialect despite scholarly consensus to the contrary captures the colonial logic of linguistic suppression.

Sahu's poem *Mithilāk Piyās* (Mithila's Thirst) directly addresses this: "So long as Maithili is not the language of all people in Mithila / Mithila's thirst will not be quenched." The poem diagnoses the internal divisions within the Maithili-speaking community that have prevented linguistic solidarity — a diagnosis that Fanon (*The Wretched of the Earth*, 1961) makes in the anticolonial context: the colonized people's internal divisions serve the colonial interest.

### 3.2.5 Ecocriticism and the Koshi Ecology

The Koshi River — Bihar's "Sorrow," the most flood-prone river in South Asia — appears throughout Sahu's work as both landscape and character. The poem *Kosīme Samāel Jinagī* (Life swallowed by the Koshi) addresses the Koshi floods directly; the story *Vargak Sukh* (Class/Heaven's Joy) is set on the Koshi riverbank where the Dom family Baukaū lives. The *Balānak Bādh* (Balan Embankment) poem addresses flood control infrastructure. *Dukhāel Gaṃgā* (The Suffering Ganga) addresses river pollution.

Lawrence Buell's criteria for ecocritical writing (*The Environmental Imagination*, 1995) — that it presents the non-human environment not as backdrop but as active presence; that it shows human interest as not the only legitimate interest; that human accountability to the natural environment is part of the text's ethical orientation — all apply to Sahu's ecological imagination. For Sahu, the Koshi River is not scenery but an active force: it can drown

communities, destroy crops, and displace families. The farmer's relationship to rain, drought, river, and soil is not background but the very substance of the poetry.

### 3.2.6 New Criticism and the Formal Architecture of Seed Stories

Cleanth Brooks's principle that poetry (and by extension all literary art) works through *ironic unity* — the productive tension between opposed elements held together in a single form — illuminates the structure of Sahu's seed stories. Each story is built around a constitutive irony:

- "Cor-Sipāhī": The law-enforcer (constable) is outwitted by the lawbreaker (thief).
- "Imāndārīk Pāṭh": Honesty means staying rural and poor; the city school teaches "employability" which means abandoning family and village.
- "Ghūshā Ghar Mukhiyājī": The housing scheme meant for the poor becomes a mechanism of extraction from the poor.
- "Jātik Bhōj": The feast that requires all castes' labour excludes them all from eating.
- "Ī Chī Hamr Majbūrī": The preacher who teaches equality publicly cannot practice it privately.
- "Ḍomak Āgi": The Dom is untouchable in life, indispensable at death.
- "Vargak Sukh": The poorest family has the richest joy.

These ironic structures are not rhetorical devices but the essential form of each story: the irony *is* the meaning, not a vehicle for some other meaning. This is Brooks's argument applied to Maithili seed fiction.

## *3.3 The Videha Parallel History Framework*

### 3.3.1 Sahu in the Parallel Canon

The Videha Parallel History (as documented at www.videha.co.in) argues that mainstream Maithili literary institutions have systematically promoted an upper-caste (Brahmin-centred) canon while suppressing the democratic, subaltern, Dalit, feminist, and OBC traditions. Ram Vilas Sahu's work — by an OBC writer from a Madhubani village, published by Pallavi Prakashan (Nirmali, Supaul) with Videha institutional support — is a direct embodiment of the counter-canonical tradition.

The *Outlook India* interview with Ashok explicitly names Ram Vilas Sahu alongside Jagdish Prasad Mandal (Sahitya Akademi winner 2021 for *Pangu*, a Dalit farmer novel) and Umesh Mandal (Videha sub-editor) as among the writers who have "integrated a larger community with Maithili literature." This is the Parallel History's project in miniature: democratic inclusion, the expansion of the Maithili literary community beyond its traditional Brahmin core.

### 3.3.2 The Pallavi Prakashan Network

Pallavi Prakashan, Nirmali, Supaul — the publisher of Sahu's most recent works — is the same publishing and distribution network that circulates other Videha-circle books by Munnaji (Manoj Kumar Karna) and other parallel-tradition writers. The distributorship (Pallavi Distributors, Ward 6, Nirmali, Pin 847452) is the material infrastructure of the counter-canonical tradition. In the Videha Parallel History framework, this network constitutes a "living parallel institution" — an alternative to the Sahitya Akademi-Delhi axis that has historically controlled access to Maithili print culture.

### 3.3.3 The Farmer-Writer: Agricultural Imagery as Political Aesthetics

The Videha Parallel History's emphasis on writers who speak from the ground level — who document the suppressed agricultural and subaltern traditions rather than the elite court-literary tradition — finds in Ram Vilas Sahu one of its clearest embodiments. Sahu is not merely writing *about* farming; he *is* a farmer-writer, one who combines agricultural work with literary work. The agricultural imagery in his poetry — the transplanting of rice (*dhanrōpanī*), the harvesting of wheat (*gahumak kaṭanī-daonī*), the plowing, the drought, the flood — is not metaphorical decoration but direct autobiographical experience rendered as poetry.

This connects to the Videha Parallel History's documentation of the famine poetry of Faturilal (1873-74) — whose verses about agrarian suffering constituted "literature from below" that the establishment ignored. Sahu's drought poems, flood poems, and farmer-poverty poems are the contemporary continuation of this tradition: testimony from within the agrarian experience rather than from without.

## *3.4 Navya-Nyāya Epistemology: Gaṅgeśa's Framework Applied*

### 3.4.1 The Poem Karm Binu Jag Sunnā as Vyāpti Structure

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's *Tattvacintāmaṇi* (c. 1325 CE) — composed in Mithila, making it the most significant philosophical text from Sahu's own cultural geography — develops the concept of *vyāpti* (invariable concomitance) as the logical relation that grounds all valid inference. The *anumāna* (inference) form requires: a *pakṣa* (locus), a *sādhya* (property to be established), a *hetu* (reason/middle term), and a *vyāpti* (the invariable concomitance between hetu and sādhya).

Sahu's title poem *Karm Binu Jag Sunnā* is structured precisely as a systematic demonstration of *vyāpti*. Each couplet establishes a *vyāpti*: "wherever there is X, there is Y" (implicitly: "wherever there is no X, Y is empty"). The poem's rhetorical power derives from the accumulation of eighteen such *vyāptis*, each establishing the invariable concomitance between a thing and its necessary complement. The final couplet — "without work, the world is empty" — is the *sādhya* that all eighteen preceding *vyāptis* have been demonstrating by way of analogy (*upamāna*).

In Navya-Nyāya terms, the poem performs *anumāna* through *dṛṣṭāntā* (example): each couplet provides a *dṛṣṭānta* (example) that establishes the *vyāpti* "wherever absence of the essential, emptiness follows." The final application to *karm* (work) is thus not asserted but *inferred* — proven through the accumulated weight of analogical demonstration.

### 3.4.2 Pramāṇa Analysis of the Stories

Navya-Nyāya recognizes four *pramāṇas* (sources of valid knowledge): *pratyakṣa* (perception), *anumāna* (inference), *upamāna* (comparison), and *śabda* (verbal testimony). Sahu's fiction operates as *pratyakṣa* — not the raw perception of the senses but the *cognitive* pratyakṣa of a careful observer who has witnessed the scenes he describes.

The story "Bāl-Bodh" provides a meditation on *śabdapramāṇa*: the landowner's authority derives entirely from the documents (*kāgaj*) — the signed paper that transfers land rights. But the debt-bondage papers were signed through illiteracy (thumb-prints rather than signatures), meaning the *śabdapramāṇa* (verbal testimony of the document) was obtained through deception. Sahu's story thus raises a Navya-Nyāya question: what are the conditions for valid *śabdapramāṇa*? The answer is *āptavākya* — the

trustworthy, reliable, competent speaker. A document signed under coercion or obtained through deception fails the *āptatā* (reliability) condition.

The story "Ī Chī Hamr Majbūrī" (This is my compulsion) dramatizes the distinction between *pravṛttilakṣaṇa* (public knowledge, what is said) and *nivṛttilakṣaṇa* (private knowledge, what is known but cannot be said). The preacher knows the social truth (inequality is structural, not natural) but cannot communicate it through *pravacana* (public discourse) — only in private conversation with the questioning narrator. This is a meditation on the social conditions that constrain *śabdapramāṇa* — the way institutional power distorts verbal testimony.

### 3.4.3 Abhāva (Absence) as a Structural Principle

Gaṅgeśa's analysis of *abhāva* (absence) as a positive epistemological category — not merely the negation of presence but a cognizable reality — applies with unusual precision to Sahu's work. The entire poem *Karm Binu Jag Sunnā* is structured around *abhāva*: each "binu" (without) announces an absence that is itself the substance of the couplet. The poem makes absence *visible* — forces the reader to cognize the absent sun in a lightless sky, the absent cuckoo in a silent grove, the absent woman in a society that pretends she isn't foundational.

The *Navya-Nyāya* category of *atyantābhāva* (absolute absence) versus *saṃsargābhāva* (relational absence) maps onto Sahu's social critique. The story *Jātik Bhōj* dramatizes *saṃsargābhāva*: the Dom, the Kumhar, the Mali are not absolutely absent from the feast — they are present as labourers — but they are absent from a *specific relation* to it (the eating-relation, the honoured-guest relation). It is this relational absence that Sahu's story makes cognizable.

### 3.4.4 The Suppressed Gaṅgeśa and Sahu's Social Position

The Videha Parallel History's recovery of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's suppressed origins — born in Mithila of an inter-caste union, his social origins concealed by upper-caste historians — creates a structural parallel with Ram Vilas Sahu's position. Gaṅgeśa, the greatest philosophical mind Mithila produced, came from outside the Brahmin establishment and was suppressed *within his own tradition*. Sahu, writing from the OBC social location in a Madhubani village, is similarly a voice that the literary establishment has historically ignored — and that the Videha Parallel History is systematically recovering.

Gaṅgeśa's radical epistemological project — refusing to accept authority without evidence, demanding rigorous logical proof for every claim — is

mirrored in Sahu's literary method: the seed stories consistently expose the gap between what authority claims (the panchayat serves the poor, the school educates the children, the wedding feast is for everyone) and what the evidence of lived experience demonstrates. This is the literary equivalent of Navya-Nyāya's *pramāṇa-mīmāṃsā* (inquiry into the conditions of valid knowledge): Sahu's stories are investigations into what really constitutes the valid knowledge that institutions claim to possess.

## PART IV: FORMAL ANALYSIS — POETRY, TANKA, HAIKU, AND SEED FICTION

### *4.1 The Tanka and Haiku Tradition in Maithili*

Ram Vilas Sahu is among the pioneering practitioners of tanka and haiku in contemporary Maithili literature. The tanka (five-line, 31-syllable Japanese form: 5-7-5-7-7) and haiku (three-line, 17-syllable: 5-7-5) represent radical formal experiments within Maithili — a language with its own rich indigenous lyric traditions (the Vidyapati *padāvalī*, the *baramāsa*, the *nacāri*). Sahu's adoption of these Japanese forms is mediated through Hindi and by the Videha movement's commitment to global lyric forms.

His tanka consistently address ethical and social themes in compressed form, using the form's internal structural division (the 5-7-5 upper unit and the 7-7 lower unit) to create a pivot between natural image and human implication — the formal correlate of his prose style's ironic turning point.

### *4.2 The Song (Gīt) Tradition*

Several poems in *Rathak Cakkā* are explicitly *gīt* (songs) — *Caitābar Gīt* (Spring Chaiti Song), *Caiti Gīt* (Chaiti Song), *Prītak Gīt* (Love Song). These engage with the indigenous Maithili song tradition — the Chaiti (spring), the *sōhara* (birth song), the *baramāsa* (twelve-months song) — modernizing their themes while retaining their lyric structure. *Koilī Kuhkai Āmak Ḍārr* (The Cuckoo Calls on the Mango Branch) is a classic separation (*viraha*) song in the tradition of Vidyapati's *padāvalī*, reimagined in a contemporary register where the separated loved one is a *pardeshī* (migrant worker) rather than a divine lover.

### *4.3 The Seed Story as Epistemological Form*

Sahu's seed stories follow the bīhani kathā tradition that Munnaji has theorized: the extreme compression of a complex social situation into a brief narrative with a single ironic pivot. The form itself enacts the Navya-Nyāya logic of *vyāpti*: the story establishes a *pakṣa* (the specific situation), demonstrates the *hetu* (the structural cause of the situation), and through the ironic turn allows the reader to complete the inference toward the *sādhya* (the general social principle the story is demonstrating). Sahu's best seed stories — "Ghūshā Ghar Mukhiyājī," "Ḍomak Āgi," "Vargak Sukh" — achieve this economy with remarkable precision.

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## PART V: ASSESSMENT, SIGNIFICANCE, AND CONCLUSION

### *5.1 Ram Vilas Sahu's Literary Achievement*

Ram Vilas Sahu (b. 1957, Laxminiyā, Madhubani) represents, within the Videha Parallel tradition of Maithili literature, a writer whose significance derives from the convergence of social authenticity, formal versatility, and moral commitment. He writes poetry, tanka, haiku, short stories, and seed stories — across genres but from a consistent ethical centre: the world of the rural poor, the agrarian distressed, the caste-oppressed, and the gender-subordinated.

His work is significant for the following reasons:

First, it constitutes an unprecedented body of OBC/backward-caste writing within Maithili — a tradition that has historically been dominated by upper-caste voices. His emergence, enabled by the Videha network, represents the democratic broadening of the Maithili literary community that the Parallel History has championed.

Second, it directly confronts the major socio-economic crises of contemporary Bihar: the agrarian debt crisis, the Koshi floods, the failure of rural employment, the corruption of welfare schemes, the persistence of caste discrimination, the gendered injustice of dowry — all rendered through specific, concrete, formally accomplished literary works.

Third, it innovates within Maithili's formal repertoire: the tanka and haiku collections expand the generic range of Maithili poetry toward forms that

connect it to global lyric traditions while remaining rooted in Maithili's specific ecological and cultural landscape.

### *5.2 Critical Convergence*

The multi-framework analysis converges on a consistent assessment:

- **Rasa-dhvani aesthetics**: karuṇa and vīra as dominant rasas, dhvani as operative mode through the structural irony of absence (*abhāva*), vakrokti through animal allegory and narrative irony.
- **Marxist criticism**: a sustained investigation of alienated labour, class exploitation, and the structures that reproduce poverty — remarkable for its concrete specificity rather than abstract theorising.
- **Subaltern studies**: the subaltern *does* speak in Sahu's work, and speaks with moral authority and narrative precision.
- **Feminist criticism**: women in Sahu's fiction are agents — Citrā, Budhni, Radhiyā — not victims; they reason, resist, and occasionally win.
- **Post-colonial theory**: Maithili as decolonial literary act, the poem *Mithilāk Piyās* as manifesto for linguistic solidarity.
- **Ecocriticism**: the Koshi River and the agrarian ecology of North Bihar as active presences in the literary landscape.
- **Videha Parallel History**: the embodiment of the counter-canonical project — OBC writer, Nirmali publisher, Videha network.
- **Navya-Nyāya epistemology**: the poem *Karm Binu Jag Sunnā* as systematic vyāpti demonstration; the seed stories as pramāṇa investigations; the suppressed Gaṅgeśa as structural parallel to Sahu's own subaltern writerly position.

### *5.3 Final Assessment*

Ram Vilas Sahu is a writer of the village, writing *from* the village and *for* the village — not as an ethnographer looking in but as an insider speaking out. His poetry gives voice to those who work without recognition; his stories expose those who take without giving. He is a practitioner of what the Navya-Nyāya philosopher Gaṅgeśa — himself a suppressed inter-caste figure from Mithila — modelled philosophically: the rigorous, evidence-based examination of claims to authority, the refusal to accept inherited privilege as valid ground for knowledge or power.

In the twenty-first century Maithili literary landscape, Ram Vilas Sahu occupies a position that will become increasingly recognized as central: a democratic voice, a formally versatile practitioner, and a moral witness to the conditions of the rural poor in one of Bihar's most historically neglected and flood-prone regions.

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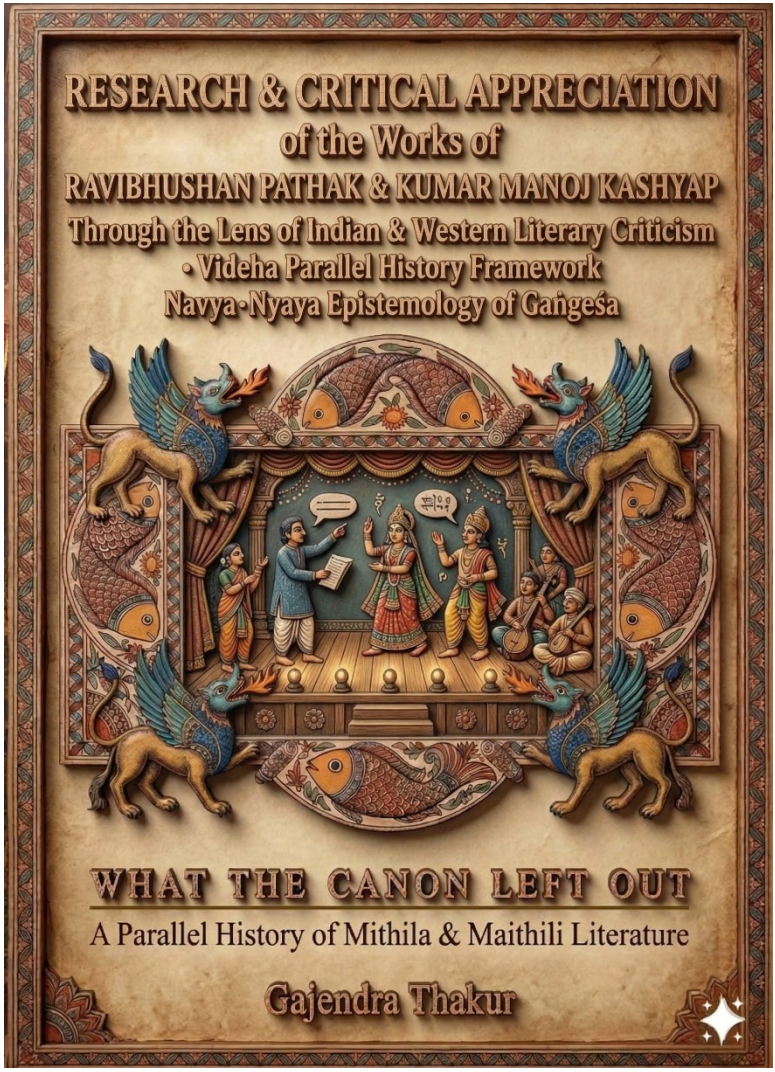
*All quotations from Maithili primary texts are the author’s translations.*

**LESSON 072 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**



# RESEARCH & CRITICAL APPRECIATION

*of the Works of*

# RAVIBHUSHAN PATHAK

&

**KUMAR MANOJ KASHYAP**

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*Through the Lens of*

Indian & Western Literary Criticism • Videha Parallel History Framework

Navya Nyaya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa

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## PREFACE AND METHODOLOGICAL NOTE

This monograph undertakes a comprehensive research and critical appreciation of the literary works of two significant contemporary Maithili writers: Ravibhushan Pathak (b. 1973) and Kumar Manoj Kashyap. Both writers have contributed substantially to the Videha e-journal (www.videha.co.in, ISSN 2229-547X), the first Maithili fortnightly e-journal, and their collected works appear in the Videha Sadeha anthology series — volumes 27, 29, and 31 — published under the Videha Maithili Sahitya Andolan movement.

The methodological approach here is deliberately pluralist and multi-perspectival, drawing on three intersecting analytical frameworks: (1) the Videha Parallel History Framework as articulated by Gajendra Thakur; (2) the epistemological and logical apparatus of Navya Nyaya, especially as developed by Gangesa Upadhyaya in the Tattvachintamani; and (3) a selection of Indian and Western critical theories — including Sanskrit rasa-dhvani aesthetics, Marxist-inflected subaltern criticism, feminist literary theory, narratology, and postcolonial theory — applied where appropriate to specific textual phenomena.

Primary sources consulted include: Rehearsal (Riharsal), a Maithili play by Ravibhushan Pathak (Shruti Prakashan, Delhi, 2011, ISBN 978-93-80538-43-3); Badalait Samay, a short story collection by Kumar Manoj Kashyap; Ek Thop Ijot (a further prose collection by Kashyap); Videha Sadeha 27 (containing Pathak's Maithili translations of Nirala's Hindi poetry); Videha Sadeha 29 (Pathak's major collected prose and verse); and Videha Sadeha 31

(containing Kashyap's prose fiction and verse). Web resources from www.videha.co.in, particularly the Parallel History pages, have also been consulted.

# PART I: THEORETICAL FRAMEWORKS

## 1.1 The Videha Parallel History Framework

The Videha Parallel History of Mithila and Maithili Literature, authored by Gajendra Thakur and published in ongoing instalments at www.videha.co.in, represents a foundational revisionist historiography. The framework identifies and contests the 'mainstream' or 'dried main drain' narrative of Maithili literature — one dominated by Brahmin-centric court culture, Sahitya Akademi selection biases, and the suppression of democratic, anti-caste, women's, and folk literary voices.

The Parallel History framework is built on several key principles. First, historiographical recovery: voices systematically excluded from canonical literary surveys — such as the Siddha poets of the Buddhist Charyapadas (8th-12th cent.), famine poets like Faturilal, Dalit dramatists like Bechan Thakur, and women writers from Vibha Rani to Panna Jha — are restored to their proper centrality. Second, demystification of caste-based institutional capture: the Sahitya Akademi awards for Maithili, the first of which (1966) went to a philosophy academic text rather than a literary work, are read as evidence of caste-based gatekeeping. Third, digital democratisation: Videha's internet presence since 2000, its ISSN registration, its Tirhuta Unicode contributions, and its archive of thousands of Maithili texts represent a parallel institution-building project.

Ravibhushan Pathak and Kumar Manoj Kashyap, as contributors to Videha since its inception, are thus not merely individual writers but participants in this broader counter-canonical movement. Their works are published, archived, and critically situated within an explicitly anti-establishment literary ecosystem. For a critical appreciation of their work, this context is indispensable: to read Pathak's play Riharsal or Kashyap's story 'Giraith Dewal' ('The Falling Wall') in isolation from the caste and class dynamics of Maithili literary culture would be to misread them fundamentally.

The Parallel History framework also situates both writers in a specific lineage: the post-independence democratic-literary tradition that includes

Rajkamal Chaudhary (the 'true avant-garde of Maithili'), Somdev, Jagdish Prasad Mandal, Rajdeo Mandal, and Bechan Thakur. Pathak and Kashyap inherit this tradition and develop it in their own distinctive registers — Pathak through translation, drama, and discursive prose; Kashyap through the concentrated form of the Maithili laghu-katha (short story) and ghazal.

## 1.2 Navya Nyaya Epistemology: Gangesa Upadhyaya and Literary Analysis

Gangesa Upadhyaya (c. 13th-14th cent.), the Mithila-born philosopher and founder of the Navya Nyaya school, authored the monumental Tattvachintamani, a systematic treatise on epistemology (pramana-shastra). The Videha Parallel History makes a striking claim about Gangesa: that panji (genealogical) research preserved in Videha's archives reveals that he was born of a Charmkarini (leather-tanning caste woman) and was born five years after his father's death — a fact suppressed by later brahminical scholars such as Ramanath Jha in an act of 'honour-killing of his legacy.'

This recovery has dual significance. Biographically, it situates Gangesa himself within the parallel, non-brahminical tradition — a philosopher of world-historical importance whose social origins were systematically erased. Theoretically, it suggests that Navya Nyaya's analytical apparatus — with its precision in defining cognitive categories (pratyaksha, anumana, upamana, shabda), its meticulous logic of vyapti (invariable concomitance), and its developed theory of sabdabodha (verbal cognition) — is available as a tool for reading literary texts across caste boundaries.

In literary analysis, Navya Nyaya's most fruitful contribution is its theory of meaning and reference. The Shabdabodha analysis — how a sentence (vakya) generates a unified, relational cognition in the hearer — maps productively onto questions of literary communication: how do the compressed sentences of a laghu-katha generate their particular impact? How does a translated poem negotiate between source-language and target-language sabdabodha structures? Ravibhushan Pathak, in his theoretical essay on translation in Videha Sadeha 27 (examining Nirala translations), explicitly invokes the Shabdarthalochintamani's dual definition of translation: 'praptasya punah kathane' (re-telling the already-known) and 'jnatarthasya pratipadane' (explicating known meaning) — a direct application of Navya Nyaya categorical precision to translational poetics.

Further, the Navya Nyaya notion of visheshana-visheshya (qualifier-qualified) relation is illuminating for Kashyap's prose style: his stories are

structured around the collision of social qualifiers (caste, gender, class) with the 'qualified' individual, revealing how abstract structures of power determine concrete personal fates. The analytical precision of Navya Nyaya — distinguishing types of absence (abhava), types of relation (sambandha), and types of inference — provides a rigorous vocabulary for describing the logical architecture of both Pathak's essays and Kashyap's fictions.

## 1.3 Indian Critical Traditions: Rasa, Dhvani, Vakrokti, and Alamkara

The Sanskrit critical tradition offers a rich set of analytical tools. Bharata's Natyashastra (c. 2nd cent. BCE-2nd cent. CE) established the theory of rasa — the emotional essences (shrngara, hasya, karuna, raudra, vira, bhayanaka, bibhatsa, adbhuta, and the later-added shanta) that constitute the aesthetic experience of literature. Anandavardhana's Dhvanyaloka (c. 9th cent.) proposed dhvani (resonance or suggestion) as the soul of poetry: the power of language to evoke meanings beyond what is explicitly stated. Kuntaka's Vakroktijivita introduced vakrokti (oblique or 'crooked' speech) as the differentia of poetic language. Bhoja's Shringaraprakasha and Mamata's Kavyaprakasha developed the alamkara (figuration) tradition further.

For Ravibhushan Pathak's play Riharsal, the dominant rasa is karuna (the tragic-pathetic), inflected with a persistent undertone of raudra (the wrathful) directed at caste discrimination. The play's treatment of the theatre troupe's internal conflicts — between the Brahmin director Hemchandra and the low-caste aspiring actor Ramapravesh — generates a sustained dhvani of social critique: the surface-level theatrical dispute resonates with deeper, unspoken tensions about who has the right to inhabit 'canonical' roles (Kalidasa, Vidyapati). Kuntaka's vakrokti is operative throughout: the language of theatrical management encodes the violence of social management.

For Kumar Manoj Kashyap's laghu-kathas, the primary aesthetic is what Sanskrit critics called svabhavokti — naturalistic depiction — combined with a powerful dhvani of social protest. Stories like 'Giraith Dewal' ('The Falling Wall'), 'Kalakaar' ('The Artiste'), and 'Bhukhala Peta' ('The Hungry Belly') achieve their effect not through rhetorical ornamentation but through precise, compressed observation that generates an extensive dhvani of injustice, deprivation, and resilience. The Kavyaprakasha's distinction between abhidha (denotative meaning), lakshana (indicative meaning), and vyanjana (suggestive meaning) is particularly relevant: Kashyap's prose operates almost

entirely at the level of vyanjana, where what is left unsaid is as powerful as what is stated.

Abhinavagupta's rasa theory, in its developed form in the Abhinavabharati, posits that aesthetic experience (rasa) is not emotion per se but a universalised, purified form of emotion achieved through the 'distancing' effect of artistic representation. This sadharanikarana (universalisation) is precisely what distinguishes Kashyap's stories from mere protest writing: the artiste-child in 'Kalakaar' is not a sociological case study but an archetypal figure, while his situation is rendered with enough documentary precision to anchor the universalised pathos.

## 1.4 Western Critical Theories Applied

From Western criticism, this study draws selectively on several traditions. Marxist literary criticism — particularly as developed by Georg Lukacs's theory of realism and later by Fredric Jameson's notion of the 'political unconscious' — provides tools for reading both Pathak's and Kashyap's works as interventions in ideological struggle. Lukacs's distinction between naturalism (mere surface description) and realism (the revelation of underlying social totality through typical characters) is illuminating for Kashyap's laghu-kathas: figures like Baitha the washerman ('Giraith Dewal') are not naturalist sketches but 'typical' in Lukacs's sense — individuals whose particular situation crystallises the structural conditions of a whole social formation.

Bakhtin's theory of the novel — particularly heteroglossia (the coexistence of multiple social voices and languages within a text) and the carnivalesque — applies productively to Pathak's play Riharsal. The drama stages a genuine heteroglossia: high-caste Sanskrit theatrical culture, subaltern folk performance, political sloganeering, and vernacular gossip all collide in an incommensurable dialogue. The carnivalesque element — the 'upside-down world' of the play-within-a-play, where low-caste characters momentarily occupy canonical roles — is simultaneously liberatory and tragically curtailed.

Postcolonial criticism, especially Homi Bhabha's concept of hybridity and the 'third space,' illuminates Pathak's translational practice. His Maithili translations of Nirala's Hindi — and his theoretical reflections on translation in Videha Sadeha 27 — constitute a 'third space' between Hindi and Maithili, between the colonial modernity of standard literary Hindi and the regional specificity of Maithili. Pathak's translation is not servile reproduction but an active negotiation: he appropriates the prestige of Nirala's oeuvre while insisting on Maithili's own phonological, grammatical, and aesthetic resources.

Feminist criticism — from Virginia Woolf's 'room of one's own' to Gayatri Spivak's 'Can the Subaltern Speak?' — is relevant to both writers, though differently. Kashyap's stories repeatedly centre women's experiences: the runaway daughter in 'Giraith Dewal,' the abandoned wives in 'Parajaa' and 'Maryada ka Hanan,' the flood-affected family in 'Bhukhala Peta.' These are not romanticised but rendered in the full complexity of double oppression — class and gender simultaneously. Pathak's translations of Nirala's poems on female figures (including 'Steh Nijhkar Bahi Gael' — 'Love Has Dried and Flowed Away') engage with grief and gender through the dhvani framework.

Narratological approaches — Gerard Genette's analysis of focalization, narrative time, and mood — provide precision tools for analysing Kashyap's short-story craft. His consistent use of third-person limited focalization, his telescoping of narrative time to the single epiphanic moment, and his preference for iterative over singulative narration (what happens again and again rather than what happened once) are all characteristic of the laghu-katha form as theorised in his own preface to Badalait Samay. Roman Jakobson's poetic function — the dominance of the message over other functions — helps explain the formal concentration of Kashyap's prose.

# PART II: RAVIBHUSHAN PATHAK — LIFE, WORKS, AND CRITICAL STUDY

## 2.1 Biography and Literary Context

Ravibhushan Pathak was born in 1973, in Karyan village, Samastipur district, Bihar, with family connections to Bhidha (Nani-gram). His education began in Karyan and Vaidyanathpur villages, continuing in Darbhanga, Samastipur, Patna, and Delhi. He served in the Uttar Pradesh Survey and Land Consolidation departments before joining as a Hindi Lecturer at Nehru Memorial Vishwanath Das Post-Graduate College, Badaun, Uttar Pradesh.

His literary career spans drama, prose, poetry, and translation. His play Riharsal (Rehearsal) was published by Shruti Prakashan, Delhi, in 2011 (ISBN 978-93-80538-43-3, priced at Rs. 50), with first staging at the occasion of the first anniversary of the Udayanachary Mithila Library, and was later included in the Videha Sadeha 29 collection. His extensive prose — including essays on Maithili poetics, Bhama's alankara theory, Dandi's lakshana, travel writings, and social critique — alongside poetry ranging from children's verses to

ghazal-inflected lyric, appears across Videha Sadeha 29 and Videha Sadeha 27. His translations in Videha Sadeha 27 include Maithili renderings of poems by Nirala, accompanied by a substantial theoretical essay on translation theory grounded in Navya Nyaya and modern linguistic thought.

Pathak's literary identity is shaped by the tension between two worlds: the agrarian, caste-saturated Maithili village culture (Samastipur, Darbhanga) and the metropolitan Hindi academic world (Delhi, Badaun). This tension generates the characteristic double-voicedness of his work — the capacity to speak simultaneously in Maithili's idiom and with the critical distance of a comparative scholar.

## 2.2 The Play Riharsal (Rehearsal): Drama and Social Critique

Riharsal is a Maithili play in two acts, set in the world of a village theatrical group ('Rang Chetana Manch') that is preparing a production. The dramatis personae — listed in the published play — include: Hemchandra, a 60-ish 'cultured and Sanskrit-directing' man; Paramesh, a 40-45 year old 'refined actor'; Ramapravesh, Paramesh's theatrical rival, alert to the prestige of low-caste identity; Dhirendra, doctor by training, naturally witty; Manu, Hemchandra's wife; and a host of supplementary characters including musicians, dancing girls (Memamaalini, Meshwarya Rai, Nina Kumari), a drunkard (Sudarshan), and ideologically aware youth (Mukhan). The cast — with its internal hierarchy of caste markers encoded in names — is itself a microcosm of Mithila's social stratosphere.

The central dramatic tension is cast with deceptive simplicity: which actor will play which role in the planned production? But this theatrical question is immediately a social question. When Ramapravesh — identified as 'of the Visar caste, alert to the prestige of low caste' — aspires to the lead roles traditionally reserved for upper-caste performers (Kalidasa, Vidyapati), the conflict that erupts is irreducible to theatrical preference. Hemchandra's management of this conflict — his bureaucratic diplomacy, his appeals to 'theatrical suitability' — is read by Pathak as the cultural hegemony of Brahmin aesthetics masking as neutral professional judgment.

The play's opening scene — Paramesh lying half-asleep to Bhairavi music, then jolted awake by Hemchandra's urgency — establishes the tone of interrupted leisure, of lives deferred in the service of 'culture.' The contrast between Hemchandra's photograph-covered walls (Vidyapati, Rabindranath, Nirala, Prasad, Mohan Rakesh, Harimohan Jha — a canon of literary authority) and Ramapravesh's spare room (Tulsi, Kabir, Marx, Nagarjuna — a counter-

canon of dissent and democracy) is one of the play's most eloquent visual statements.

*['Riharsal' natak Mithila mein vyapta sanskritik sankat ke / ek chota rupaak achhi / Mithila mein jaati badlal muda jaati ke chaali nahin badlal...] — from the play's preface*

The author's preface is explicit: Riharsal stages the cultural crisis pervading Mithila — caste has transformed in name but not in function. Caste lives on, in its perverted roles, in every domain: religion, politics, and literature have become a cocktail of caste and degraded vision.

Pathak invokes T.S. Eliot's idea — as noted in the preface — that the distance between creator and consumer is made necessary by creativity itself. This self-conscious theatricality, the 'play within a play,' is both Pathak's structural device and his critical point: Maithili theatre, particularly village theatre (gaon mein manchan), is simultaneously a site of cultural assertion and of social reproduction. The play refuses to glamourise or to romanticise the village troupe; it shows the compromises, the petty humiliations, the economic dependencies that structure 'cultural work.'

In terms of dramaturgy, Riharsal is broadly in the tradition of modern Indian theatre — naturalistic staging, conversational Maithili dialogue, and a movement toward social exposure rather than Aristotelian catharsis. Yet the play's dhvani (resonant suggestion) works against its surface naturalism: the repeated failures of theatrical 'rehearsal' resonate as the repeated failures of social reform in Mithila. The Brechtian Verfremdungseffekt — making the familiar strange — is not achieved through formal alienation devices but through the excruciating ordinariness of the social conflicts depicted. We recognise the world; the play refuses to let us be comfortable in that recognition.

From a Navya Nyaya perspective, the play dramatises the failure of vyapti (invariable concomitance) in social reasoning: the inference 'if cultured, then upper-caste' (which underlies Hemchandra's casting decisions) is exposed as a faulty vyapti through counter-examples (Ramapravesh's demonstrated talent). Pathak's dramatic logic is ultimately an epistemological one: the play is about false inferences and the social machinery that sustains them.

## 2.3 Prose Writings: Ghar Series, Diary, Vidyapati Essays

Pathak's prose in Videha Sadeha 29 is extraordinarily diverse: it ranges from the three micro-fictions of the 'Ghar' (Home) series through the essay-

diary 'Aujhaka Diary' (Today's Diary), several theoretical essays on Maithili literary history, humorous satire, and the long story 'Okkar Tohar Hammar Sapana' (Your Dream, My Dream, Their Dream).

The 'Ghar' series — three compact prose vignettes of extraordinary compression — deserves extended attention. 'Ghar (Ek)' (Home: One) captures the rhythm of domestic gossip and social positioning: the daily conversation that begins with 'My father is like this, my brother is like this,' moves through the afternoon to 'In our village, things are like this,' and concludes in the evening with 'The younger Chaudhary is like this, the middle Chaudhary is like this.' In twelve lines, Pathak maps the social grammar of Maithili family life — its competitiveness, its relativity of perspective, its absorption of political and caste discourse into the texture of domestic talk.

'Ghar (Dui)' (Home: Two) is a Proustian domestic interior: the half-washed plate left on the floor, vegetables still in the shopping bag, the mosquito net no one unfolds. The household described is one where hospitality has atrophied — where the possibility of a guest occasions only anxiety and the scramble to hide disorder rather than the joy of welcome. Pathak's satire here is gentle but precise: the 'stable earth, guest-free universe' at the vignette's close is simultaneously funny and melancholy.

'Ghar (Teen)' (Home: Three) introduces 'Anand Ji' and his cooking rota, his mother's remembered admonition ('Eat up, son, don't leave a grain'), and the rationalisation of contemporary urban domestic arrangements. The mother's voice — introduced as memory — functions as the moral anchor of the trilogy: a voice of rural communal sufficiency that persists, transformed and attenuated, in metropolitan apartment life.

The essay 'Aacharya Bhamah ka Chintan' (The Thought of Acharya Bhama) and the companion piece 'Dandi aa Kavyalakshan' (Dandi and the Definition of Poetry) represent Pathak as scholar-critic, engaging directly with the Indian alamkara tradition. Pathak reads Bhama's Kavyalamkara and Dandi's Kavyadarsha not as museum pieces but as living theoretical resources: their debates about what constitutes the differentia of poetic language (shabda-artha 'sahite,' or word-meaning-together) are brought into dialogue with modern linguistic theory (Jakobson, Saussure) and with the specific challenges of Maithili poetic composition. This is Indian literary-critical thinking at its most productive: neither reverent antiquarianism nor dismissive modernism, but a genuine engagement across time.

## 2.4 Poetry: Nirala Translations and Original Verse

Ravibhushan Pathak's contribution to Maithili poetry falls into two broad categories: original Maithili verse and translations from Hindi (principally Nirala). Both are collected extensively in Videha Sadeha 29 (poetry section, pp. 794-898), with the Nirala translations presented with theoretical apparatus in Videha Sadeha 27.

The original poems range from children's verse (Baal Kavita) — 'Mausam,' 'Sun Chhoua Sun,' 'Black Hole' — to satirical verse, seasonal lyric, and what might be called 'verse-essays': poems that carry an argumentative load alongside lyric freight. 'Holi,' 'Chhath,' 'Hamara Maithili' — poems of cultural and seasonal celebration — demonstrate Pathak's capacity for accessible lyric. 'Fasali Padya' (Seasonal/Cropped Verse), 'Maranoprant' (After Death), 'Bamhe Gam Dahine Gam' (Left Side Village, Right Side Village) — six-poem sequence — show his more ambitious, formally experimental side.

The Nirala translations in Videha Sadeha 27 — 'Nirala: Deh Videh 1-4' — represent Pathak's most sustained single literary project. The four instalments render well-known Nirala poems into Maithili: 'Baandho Na Naav Is Thaanv Bandhu' (Do Not Moor the Boat Here, Friend), 'Kinara Woh Hamse Kiye Jaa Rahe Hain' (The Shore is Moving Away from Us), 'Sneh Nijhkar Bah Gaya Hai' (Love Has Dried and Flowed Away), 'Rang Gayi Dhara, Bhela Dhanya Dhara' (The Earth Has Coloured, the Earth Has Been Blessed), 'Sakhi Vasant Aaaya' (Dear Friend, Spring Has Come), and 'Nadal Kari Kari Badar' (The Massing Dark Clouds).

Pathak's theoretical introduction to the translation series is itself a major scholarly contribution. Drawing on Navya Nyaya's distinction between praptasya punah kathane and jnatarthasya pratipadane, and on Roman Jakobson's definition of translation as 'interpretation of verbal signs by means of other verbal signs of another language,' he develops a sophisticated typology of translation modes: shabdanuvad (literal), bhavanuvad (sense-for-sense), rupantaran (adaptation), chayanuvad (selective translation), and tikापरक anuvad (commentary translation). He situates his own Nirala translations within the bhavanuvad tradition while acknowledging the vakya-ghatana (sentence construction), laya (rhythm), chhanda (metre), and bimba (image) challenges specific to poetry.

A particularly illuminating moment in Pathak's theoretical discussion is his observation on the shared Sanskrit-Prakrit-Apabhramsha heritage of Maithili and Khari Boli Hindi: the two languages, far from being polar

opposites, share phonological, grammatical, and lexical roots that both facilitate and complicate translation. The word 'rati' (night) exists in Maithili and many North Indian languages but is absent from standard Hindi — where 'raat' is preferred. This phonological micro-comparison is offered not as antiquarian curiosity but as translational principle: the translator must navigate the 'ubhayniShTha adhar' (shared foundation) while honouring each language's distinctiveness.

## 2.5 Translation Theory and Practice in Pathak

Pathak's practice as a translator-theorist positions him within a tradition of Maithili scholar-translators that includes Sureendra Jha Suman (whose Maithili Anugitanjali remains the gold standard of Maithili translation) and Gajendra Thakur's own multilingual translation work in Videha. The essay in Sadeha 27 explicitly cites Suman's translation as a benchmark of 'bhavanuvad at its finest' — praised by Bengali scholars over Hindi translations of Tagore's Gitanjali.

What distinguishes Pathak's translation practice is his insistence on what might be called 'acoustic fidelity': the conviction that the sound-world of the original poem — its varna-maithri (phonetic friendship), its laya (rhythmic pulse) — must find an equivalent, not merely an analogue, in the target language. This is not mere sound-symbolism but a theoretically grounded position: following Anandavardhana's dhvani theory, Pathak holds that the 'soul of poetry' — its resonant suggestion — is inseparable from the phonic texture of the language. To translate a poem is thus not only to transfer meaning but to reconstitute a sonic environment.

The practical consequences are visible in his Nirala translations. Where Nirala writes 'विजन वन वल्लरी' (vijana-vana-vallari — isolated forest creeper), Pathak retains the Sanskrit compound because, as he explicitly notes, the phonetic cluster is irreplaceable — it would be 'robbed' in any paraphrase. His translation philosophy is thus neither purely domesticating (adapting the poem entirely to Maithili norms) nor purely foreignising (preserving the alien texture of the Hindi), but a calibrated 'percolation' (parekaray-pravesh) — the translator entering the 'mental world of the original work' and then re-emerging in the target language.

### 2.6 Critical Appreciation: Rasa, Dhvani, and Parallel History

Ravibhushan Pathak's significance in the Videha Parallel History framework is multi-dimensional. As a dramatist, he extends the tradition of Maithili social drama (from Harimohan Jha's satirical novels to Bechan Thakur's caste-confronting theatre) into a new, self-reflexive mode: Riharsal is not merely social drama but meta-theatre — a drama about the social conditions of dramatic production itself. As a translator, he continues the democratic-cultural project of making world literary heritage available in Maithili — a project with both political and aesthetic dimensions. As a prose essayist, he bridges the Sanskrit critical tradition and contemporary theory.

The dominant rasa of Pathak's oeuvre is an interplay of karuna (the pathetic) and vira (the heroic) — with persistent comic relief generated by his satirical verse. The karuna — the grief of deferred recognition, of caste-blocked talent, of a language's struggles to assert its place — is never purely sentimental because it is always grounded in the specific, documented textures of Maithili social life. The dhvani of social critique suffuses even his most personal lyric. In the Navya Nyaya terms that Pathak himself favours: his literary work produces a valid anumana (inference) — from the particulars of Samastipur to the universals of social injustice — through the vyapti of artistic fidelity to observed reality.

## PART III: KUMAR MANOJ KASHYAP — LIFE, WORKS, AND CRITICAL STUDY

### 3.1 Biography and Literary Context

Kumar Manoj Kashyap is a Maithili prose writer and poet, working primarily in the form of the laghu-katha (short story/flash fiction). His collections include Badalait Samay (Changing Times: A Collection of Maithili Short Stories), Ek Thop Ijot (A Drop of Light), and numerous stories and poems published across Videha e-journal issues 1-350, collected in Videha Sadeha 31 (jointly with Dr Kamini Kamayani).

According to his own autobiographical preface in Badalait Samay, Kashyap's creative life began with the storytelling of his 'Ba' (grandmother) and mother, whose nightly tales ('khissa-pihani') instilled a narrative imagination. He recalls submitting poetry and stories to children's magazines like Balak,

Chandamama, and Balbharati in his school years, even recycling unstamped postage from neighbours' letters to fund his submissions. A brief period of publication success ('jab bhi koi rachna chaap jaay, aseem aanand ki anubhuti milti thi') was interrupted when his grandfather — on being told of his literary ambitions — delivered a counter-narrative about the poverty of literary life, illustrated by Nirala's biography, and redirected him toward employment. Kashyap notes that his grandfather's invocation of the Sarojasmarti's most painful stanzas ('dhanye, main pita nirzaak tha...') still moves him when he encounters them.

Kashyap thus writes from within a tension that is itself paradigmatically Maithili-modern: the tension between the inherited literary impulse (the grandmother's khissa) and the institutional pressure toward 'azaak rozgar' (honest employment). His career in government service ('sarkari seva') has not extinguished his writing but has shaped it: time-scarce writing produces formal compression, and formal compression is the defining quality of the laghu-katha. His wife Pratima Manoj and daughter Kritika are acknowledged in the preface as collaborators in the literary project — in selection, editing, and computer typing of the collection.

## 3.2 Badalait Samay: The Short Story Collection

Badalait Samay (Changing Times) collects 45 short stories (laghu-kathas) in Maithili. The collection's preface is itself a genre-theoretical essay of considerable sophistication. Kashyap argues that the laghu-katha has established itself as an independent literary form with its own 'svaruup, shilp, ekonmukhi samvedana, aur prabhavikata' (distinct form, craft, singular sensitivity, and effectiveness). He notes that 'Maithili sahitya seho ehi mein besi pathuyayal nai achhi' — Maithili literature is not far behind in this form — and positions the collection as a contribution to that tradition.

His theory of the laghu-katha is precise: unlike the story (katha) and novel (upanyas), the laghu-katha demands 'shabd-sanyam' (word-economy), 'anubhuti ki teevrata' (intensity of feeling), and 'shilp-kaushal' (craft-skill). The popular saying he quotes — 'dekhne mein chhotan lage, ghav kare gambhir' (small in appearance, deep the wound) — is both a definition and an aspiration. The form's brevity is not limitation but power: like an arrow, it concentrates its force.

Among the collection's most significant stories: 'Giraith Dewal' (The Falling Wall) — the story of Baitha the washerman, whose daughter elopes, and the village's reaction. This story is structurally shaped by the collision between

Baitha's resigned acceptance ('if I couldn't arrange her marriage, she has found her own way — what's the great matter?') and the village community's outrage. Kashyap's narrative management is precise: the free indirect discourse slides between Baitha's interiority and communal judgment, exposing the gap between lived experience and social norming.

'Kalakaar' (The Artiste) is one of Kashyap's most technically accomplished stories: a child of seven or eight performs extraordinary acrobatics — fire-hoops, contortion, pole-walking — at a city intersection, and then holds out a tin bowl, begging. The story turns on the contrast between the audience's 'mugdha, chakat' (enchanted, astonished) response to the performance and its collective amnesia when the light turns green and traffic resumes: the artistry is forgotten, the poverty ignored. The final sentence — 'ek baar o phir se pratiksha kar rahal chal batti ke lal heba kel... kismat ke kona bharosa?' (once again he was waiting for the signal to turn red... what reliance can be placed on fate?) — is a masterclass in dhvani: the red light becomes the symbol of deferred hope, and 'fate' carries the full weight of structural injustice.

'Bhukhala Peta' (The Hungry Belly) is the story of Harkhoo and the Kosi flood that sweeps away his crop. Written in the tradition of Mithila's flood literature (comparable to Faturilal's famine poetry within the Parallel History framework), it captures the specific texture of agricultural poverty in the Kamla-Kosi flood plain: the bataai (sharecropping) system that offers no cushion against disaster, the social humiliation of debt, the complete absence of state support. The metaphor of the flood as 'Sursa' — the monster who expands her mouth endlessly — with Harkhoo lacking Hanuman's capacity to escape, is drawn from the Ramayana but deployed with full ironic force.

'Doo Tappi' (Two Thongs), the opening story, serves as the collection's manifesto: through the story of a cobbler (Sutar — 'name 'Baitha' but always standing'), Kashyap establishes his thematic preoccupations (labour, caste, dignity, the gap between name and reality) and his tonal register (compassionate, unsentimental, precise). The pun on the cobbler's name — 'Baitha' (literally 'Seated') but always on his feet — is representative of Kashyap's verbal economy: a single detail that carries biographical, social, and philosophical weight simultaneously.

The collection's arrangement — from domestic micro-stories to flood narrative, from satire to tragedy — demonstrates Kashyap's range. But what unifies the collection is a consistent ethical stance: the refusal of easy consolation. These stories do not end in triumph, redemption, or even clear-

eyed resolve. They end in the ongoing fact of injustice, with the occasional glint of human dignity that makes that injustice bearable to witness.

## 3.3 Ek Thop Ijot: A Drop of Light

Ek Thop Ijot (A Drop of Light) represents a further dimension of Kashyap's prose: while the title suggests the lyrical (ijot/light as metaphor for hope, knowledge, or artistic illumination), the stories maintain the same commitment to social realism as Badalait Samay. The very title is characteristic of Kashyap's aesthetic: the 'thop' (drop) of light is a minimal, fragile thing — neither the flood of revolutionary transformation nor the steady glow of reformist progress, but a small, precarious illumination in conditions of general darkness.

The book, published as part of the Videha archive and available at videha.co.in/pothi.htm, extends Kashyap's range into new thematic territory while maintaining formal consistency. Stories from the collection appearing in Videha Sadeha 31 — including 'Vivashta' (Helplessness), 'Marichika' (Mirage), 'Parajaa' (Subject/Subjugated), 'Maryada ka Hanan' (The Destruction of Dignity), and 'Pratirodh' (Resistance) — show the social landscape expanding: from village Mithila to urban spaces, from agrarian poverty to service-sector precarity, from gender to political corruption.

'Parajaa' (Subject) — which appears in both Badalait Samay and Sadeha 31 with possible revision — deserves particular attention. The word 'Parjaa' in Maithili carries both the meaning of 'subject' (citizen under a ruler) and a more archaic feudal connotation of 'tenant/dependent.' Kashyap's title thus sets up a multiple reference: the story's protagonist is simultaneously a subject of the state, a tenant of a landlord, and a 'subject' in the grammatical sense — one who acts but only within structures not of his making. The story's dhvani turns on the impossibility of any of these positions being the source of genuine agency.

## 3.4 Stories in Videha Sadeha 31

Videha Sadeha 31 collects Kashyap's prose (pp. 255-336) and verse (pp. 473-479) alongside Dr Kamini Kamayani's work. The prose stories include: Vivashta, Marichika, Parajaa, Maryada ka Hanan, Pratirodh, Drishtikon, O ta Batah Achhi, Dharmatma, Manastap, Giraith Dewal, Kalakaar, Nor-Angor, Fyuz Balb, Pahil Chitthi, Din Marabay Teen Naam, Ghuri Aau Nisha, Anher, Seemaan, Ujdal Khonta, Marichika, Parajaa, Badalait Samay (title story), Jaral Peta, Jitak Aagu, Mata Kumata Na Bhavati, Eemandar,

Master Saheb, Kachot, Nav-Varsh, Vakal Baat, Haaral Manukh, Bhavna, B.D.O.

Several of these stories represent Kashyap at his most formally inventive. 'Fyuz Balb' (Fused Bulb) — the story of an exhausted, non-functional light bulb — uses the conceit of the bulb as extended metaphor for the Indian government functionary (particularly the B.D.O., Block Development Officer): present in form, absent in function, unable to illuminate. The satirical mode here is reminiscent of Harimohan Jha's satirical tradition in Maithili, though Kashyap's irony is drier and more restrained.

'Pahil Chitthi' (The First Letter) and 'Nav-Varsh' (New Year) work through the contrast between the promise of new beginnings (a first letter, a new year) and the persistence of old oppressions. The temporal framing — the 'first' and the 'new' — sets up an ironic counterpoint with the stories' conclusions, in which nothing is truly new and the first letter carries the same burdens as all subsequent ones. This irony of temporal expectation is characteristic of Kashyap's structural thinking.

'Master Saheb' (The Teacher) joins 'Giraith Dewal' and 'Kalakaar' as one of Kashyap's most fully realised character studies. The teacher figure — respected nominally but actually marginalised, economically precarious, morally earnest in a world of pragmatic compromise — is a recurring type in Maithili fiction (cf. Jagdish Prasad Mandal's teacher characters). Kashyap's Master Saheb is neither idealised nor satirised but rendered with full ambivalence: a man whose moral seriousness is both admirable and insufficient.

## 3.5 Poetry: Vasanti Doha, Ghazals

Kumar Manoj Kashyap's poetry, collected in Videha Sadeha 31 (pp. 473-479), includes Vasanti Doha (seasonal couplets in the doha metre), a devotional poem ('Nahin Suti Rahab Ahan Chaddari Tani' — 'I Will Not Lie Down under Your Sheet'), and several ghazals. The doha tradition — associated with the bhakti poets Kabir and Dadu, and with the medieval Maithili poet tradition — is itself a form freighted with both spiritual and social significance. Kashyap's Vasanti Doha (Spring Couplets) deploy the form's compressed two-line structure for lyric observation of seasonal change, with an undertone of social longing that echoes the bhakti tradition's use of seasons as metaphors for spiritual and social states.

The ghazals are composed in a Maithili that navigates the classical Urdu-Persian ghazal tradition (matla, maqta, radif, qafia) with the phonological and lexical resources of Maithili. The ghazal form — always slightly foreign in Maithili, as it was imported from the Urdu-Maithili contact zone — is here used to express the themes of loss, longing, and identity that Kashyap elsewhere develops in prose: the 'maqta' (concluding couplet) of each ghazal contains the 'takhallus' (pen-name marker) and typically crystallises the poem's emotional argument.

## 3.6 Critical Appreciation: Narrative Theory, Subaltern Perspectives

Kumar Manoj Kashyap's significance within the Videha Parallel History framework is as a representative of a new generation of Maithili laghu-katha writers who extend the democratic-realist tradition of Jagdish Prasad Mandal and Bechan Thakur into the register of compressed, urban, and semi-urban modernity. His stories are not village panoramas (the mode of Mandal's novels) but focused, intense illuminations of single moments, single decisions, single interactions — the form of the laghu-katha calibrated to the time-compressed life of modern Maithili-speaking communities in Bihar, Delhi, and the diaspora.

From a subaltern-studies perspective, Kashyap's stories perform a crucial act of 'literary ventriloquism' — speaking for, but critically not on behalf of, those whose voices are structurally excluded from literary representation. The washerman Baitha, the child acrobat, the flood-affected sharecropper Harkhoo, the fused-bulb government functionary — these figures are not statistics or case studies but fully realised subjects whose interiority is granted full narrative dignity even as their structural powerlessness is unflinchingly depicted. This is the 'praxis' of Gramscian organic intellectual: the writer as mediator between subaltern experience and literary form.

The Navya Nyaya lens offers a further angle: Kashyap's stories are structured around the failure of valid inference. In each story, a character or community makes a faulty anumana — inferring from observable 'linga' (marks) to conclusions that the social world refuses to validate. Baitha infers that his daughter's elopement represents a practical solution; the village infers that it represents a moral catastrophe. The acrobat child infers that skill will be rewarded; the passing traffic infers that charity is optional. The stories stage the collision of these incompatible inferential systems and resist any easy resolution. In this sense, Kashyap's fiction is, at a deep structural level, a

literature of epistemological crisis — a literature about the failure of social cognition.

# PART IV: COMPARATIVE ANALYSIS

## 4.1 Thematic Convergences and Divergences

Ravibhushan Pathak and Kumar Manoj Kashyap share several thematic preoccupations: the injustice of caste hierarchy, the dignity of labour, the condition of Maithili language and culture under multiple pressures (Hindi hegemony, urban migration, institutional neglect), and the moral complexity of individuals navigating unjust systems. Both writers work within a broadly realist mode, grounded in the specific social textures of Maithili rural and semi-urban life.

But their divergences are equally instructive. Pathak is drawn to the discursive, the theoretical, the comparative: his essays on Bhama, Dandi, and translation theory; his long story 'Okkar Tohar Hammar Sapana'; his satirical verse — all reflect a writer who wants to think as well as feel, to argue as well as evoke. Kashyap, by contrast, works almost entirely in the mode of concentrated lyric-narrative: the laghu-katha as refined instrument of compressed social observation. Pathak's range is broader; Kashyap's focus is more intense. Pathak's dominant tone is ironic-melancholic; Kashyap's is compassionate-analytic.

The treatment of gender illustrates this divergence. Pathak's Riharsal uses women characters — the dancing girls Memamaalini, Meshwarya Rai, and Nina Kumari — as markers of the commodification of culture under patriarchy, but they remain peripheral to the drama's central conflict (which is between male theatrical actors). Kashyap's stories consistently foreground women's experiences — the eloping daughter, the abandoned wife, the flood-affected mother — and grant them full narrative centrality. In the Videha Parallel History's terms, Kashyap's fiction more consistently performs the inclusion of women's voices that the parallel tradition advocates.

## 4.2 Place within Videha Parallel History

Both Pathak and Kashyap occupy a specific position within the Videha Parallel History: they are 'established-parallel' writers — established enough to have book-length collections archived in the Videha pothisangraham, but

operating entirely outside the Sahitya Akademi mainstream. Their work appears alongside translations (by Pathak) and alongside more experimental voices (Kamini Kamayani in Sadeha 31), suggesting the Videha platform's commitment to a genuinely diverse literary ecosystem.

Pathak's position is particularly interesting in light of the Navya Nyaya/Gangesa dimension of the Parallel History. His theoretical essay on translation — with its explicit invocation of the Shabdarthalochintamani — positions him as a writer who consciously claims the Mithila intellectual tradition (including its most illustrious export, Navya Nyaya) for the democratic-parallel literary project. This is a significant act of intellectual appropriation: reclaiming Gangesa from the brahminical hagiography that would make him a caste symbol, and deploying his analytical apparatus in the service of literary democratisation.

Kashyap's position is that of the 'ordinary extraordinary' writer — the writer who achieves significance not through formal experiment or theoretical provocation but through the accumulated force of precisely observed, compassionately rendered social truth. In the Parallel History's terms, he represents the tradition of Jagdish Prasad Mandal (Maithili's most important contemporary novelist, finally awarded the Sahitya Akademi in 2021): writers who document the lived texture of subaltern Maithili experience with unswerving fidelity.

## 4.3 Navya Nyaya Reading of Their Poetics

A Navya Nyaya reading of both writers might focus on their shared commitment to what, in Gangesa's terms, is the primacy of pratyaksha (direct perception) as the basis of valid cognition. Both Pathak and Kashyap resist abstraction: their work is grounded in the concrete — the specific Maithili village, the specific character, the specific social transaction. This commitment to the perceptually grounded is, in Navya Nyaya terms, an epistemic virtue: knowledge begins in direct encounter with the world, not in inherited categories.

At the same time, both writers practise what Gangesa calls anumana (inferential cognition): moving from the observed particular to the inferred general. Kashyap's stories move from the specific case (Baitha, Harkhoo, the child acrobat) to the general condition (caste, flood, poverty) through the vyapti of artistic form. Pathak's essays move from the specific text (Nirala's poem, Bhama's sutra) to the general principle (translation theory, poetics). The direction of movement is different — narrative fiction reasons from particular

to universal, critical essay from universal to particular — but the logical structure of inference is shared.

The most distinctively Navya Nyaya element in both writers is their attention to what might be called 'negation as presence' — the Navya Nyaya notion of abhava (absence) as itself a category of cognition. Kashyap's stories are structured around absences: the absent father, the absent harvest, the absent audience for the performing child. Pathak's critical essays are structured around the absence of recognition — the absence of the Sahitya Akademi award for Harimohan Jha in 1967, the absence of Gangesa's true biography from standard accounts. In both cases, what is absent is as real and as cognitively significant as what is present — a fully Navya Nyaya insight.

## PART V: CONCLUSION

The critical appreciation of Ravibhushan Pathak and Kumar Manoj Kashyap reveals two writers of significant literary distinction who have chosen to work within the Maithili literary tradition at a moment of crisis and renewal. Both have committed their literary labour to the Videha parallel tradition: a tradition that insists on the democratic, multi-caste, multi-gender, digitally democratised nature of Maithili literature against the brahminical mainstream represented by the Sahitya Akademi establishment.

Pathak's contribution is characterised by range — the capacity to move between drama, prose, poetry, critical essay, and translation — and by theoretical depth. His play Riharsal is a landmark of Maithili social drama; his translation theory is the most sophisticated produced in contemporary Maithili; his essays on Sanskrit poetics connect the Mithila intellectual tradition (including Navya Nyaya) to the living practice of literary criticism. He is, in a precise sense, both a practitioner and a theorist of the Parallel History.

Kashyap's contribution is characterised by formal intensity — the concentrated power of the laghu-katha perfected through decades of patient observation and compression. His stories are not politically loud but sociologically precise; not rhetorically inflated but affectively resonant; not formally experimental but structurally sophisticated. He is the 'master of the small form' in the tradition that Harimohan Jha and Jagdish Prasad Mandal established: the tradition of subaltern social realism in Maithili.

Together, they represent the Videha parallel tradition at its strongest: diverse in mode, unified in commitment, grounded in the specific textures of

Maithili life, and oriented toward the democratic vision of Mithila's literary culture as it ought to be — not as a preserve of caste privilege but as the common heritage of all Maithili speakers, whatever their birth.

In the language of Navya Nyaya: their anumana (literary inference) rests on a valid vyapti (invariable concomitance) — the connection between artistic honesty and social truth — and produces knowledge (prama) that the mainstream cannot suppress, however much it may seek to. In the language of dhvani theory: their works' resonance (dhvani) exceeds their explicit meaning, generating the surplus of significance that is the mark of literature that endures. In the language of the Videha Parallel History: they are, in the deepest sense, Maithili writers — writers for whom Maithili is not a dialect of something else, not a minor tongue, but a complete linguistic and cultural universe deserving of the fullest critical attention.

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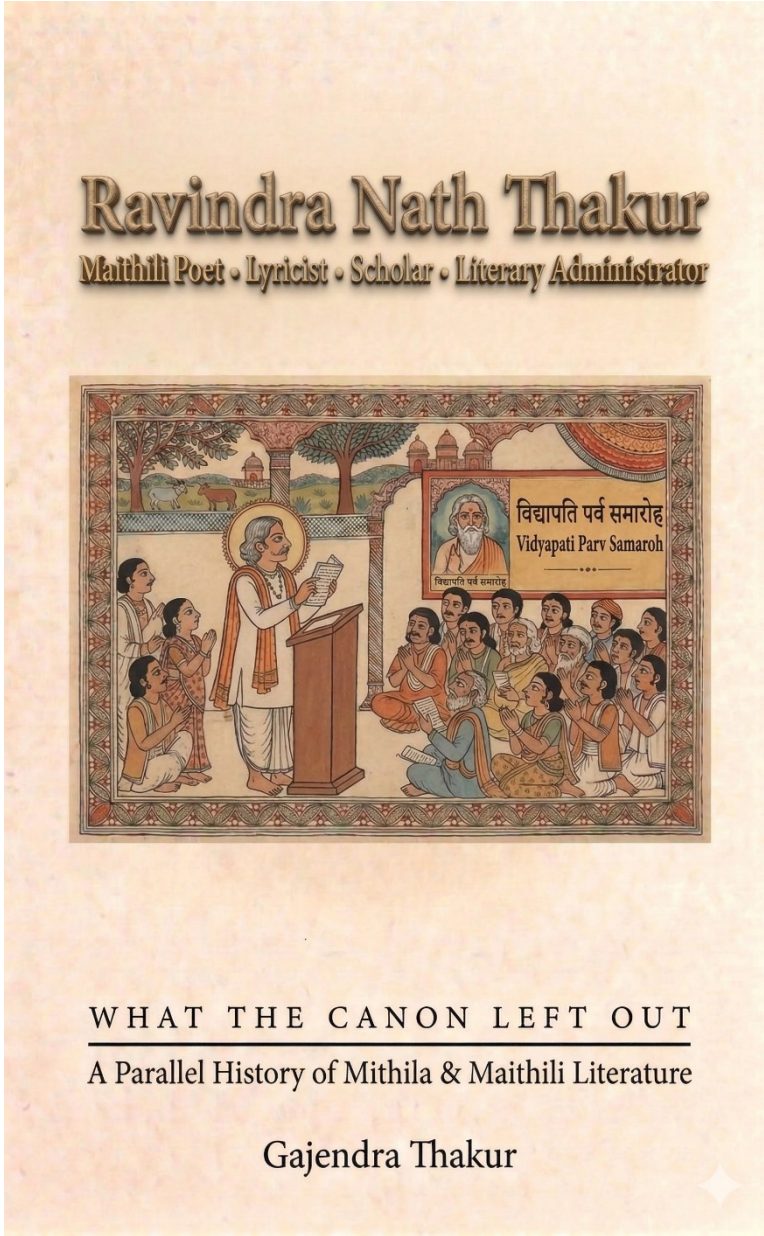
**LESSON 073 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**




# Ravindra Nath Thakur

Maithili Poet · Lyricist · Scholar · Literary Administrator

*Former Director-cum-Secretary, Maithili Academy, Bihar Government*

| | |
|---|---|
| **Full Name** | Ravindra Nath Thakur (रवीन्द्र नाथ ठाकुर) |
| **Date of Birth** | 8 August 1938 (some sources: 1936) |
| **Place of Birth** | Nanour village, Madhubani District (maternal); Dhamnaha, Purnia District (paternal) |
| **Date of Passing** | 18 May 2022, Noida, Uttar Pradesh |
| **Age at Passing** | Approximately 83 years |
| **Cause of Death** | Cancer (approx. 18 months illness) |
| **Last Rites** | Haridwar, Uttarakhand |
| **Family** | Three sons, two daughters; son Avindr Thakur, music educator |
| **Primary Languages** | Maithili, Hindi, Sanskrit |
| **Pen Name / Title** | ‘Abhinav Vidyapati’ (conferred by Baba Nagarjuna personally) |

## 1. Introduction and Historical Significance

Ravindra Nath Thakur (1938–2022) occupies a singular position in modern Maithili literary culture. Over six decades of sustained creative work, he transformed the landscape of Maithili song, drama, and verse, reaching audiences that no literary text could have reached on its own. His significance lies not merely in the quantity of his output—nineteen published volumes and hundreds of recorded songs—but in the qualitative shift he brought about: he made Maithili performance culture a vehicle for the aspirations of ordinary

people, migrant workers, women at the margins of domestic life, and farmers confronting debt and drought.

The Videha Ravindranath Thakur Visheshank (Special Issue 348, June 2022), edited by Gajendra Thakur, was announced in November 2021 and published shortly after Thakur's passing on 18 May 2022. It represents the most comprehensive scholarly and testimonial assessment of his life and work yet assembled—drawing on essays, critical reviews, personal reminiscences, and formal assessments by critics including Pradeep Pushpa, Ajit Kumar Jha, Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil', Narayanji, Laxman Jha Sagar, Dr. Kailash Kumar Mishra, and Ashish Anchinhar.

## 2. Biographical Profile

### 2.1 Early Life and Education

Ravindra Nath Thakur was born on 8 August 1938 (the year 1936 appears in some published sources, but the date given by Thakur himself via Facebook posts is 1938). His maternal family home was in Nanour village, Madhubani District—the heartland of Mithila—while his paternal family was from Dhamnaha, Purnia District, Bihar. These dual roots gave him intimate familiarity with both the Madhubani cultural zone and the Purnia plains.

His early schooling was completed in his maternal village. He then studied at the Sanskrit Secondary School, Dhamnaha, Purnia, before moving to Purnia College, Purnia, where he took his undergraduate degree. This Sanskrit-grounded education left a permanent mark on his sensibility: his songs drew on Vedic metres, classical Maithili padavali traditions, and the folk repertoire with equal fluency.

### 2.2 Professional Career

After completing his education, Thakur served briefly as a temporary teacher at Dhamnaha Secondary School and later as founding headmaster of Madhyamik Vidyalaya Dungura, Bhavanipura. He then joined the Finance Department (National Savings Organisation) of the Bihar Government in 1960, retiring in 1980 as a Gazetted Officer (rajpatrit pad adhikari).

Following retirement, he was called back into active service through deputation to the Maithili Academy established by the Bihar State Education Department.

He served there successively as Assistant Director, Deputy Director, and Director-cum-Secretary. His tenure at the Maithili Academy was marked by one signal achievement above all others: the publication of the first two-volume Maithili dictionary, a milestone in the standardisation and institutionalisation of the language.

## Administrative Role: Maithili Academy

Beyond his creative work, Ravindra Nath Thakur made a major institutional contribution to the Maithili language movement in Bihar through his service as Director-cum-Secretary of the Maithili Academy, a body constituted by the Bihar government's Education Department.

The Maithili Academy was Bihar's governmental mechanism for promoting, publishing, and institutionally supporting the Maithili language and literature. As its Director-cum-Secretary, Ravindra Nath Thakur occupied a key position at the intersection of literary culture and state patronage — analogous to the role of a literary administrator working within a formal institutional framework to advance the cause of a regional language that had historically struggled for recognition.

This role was of particular significance given the long campaign for Maithili's recognition. The Sahitya Akademi (India's National Academy of Letters) had recognised Maithili in 1965, but it was not until 2003 that Maithili was included in the Eighth Schedule of the Indian Constitution as one of India's recognised scheduled languages. Working within the Bihar government's Maithili Academy, Thakur was part of the administrative apparatus that sustained and promoted the language through this critical period of institutional consolidation.

> *The Maithili Academy under his direction would have been involved in publishing Maithili texts, supporting Maithili writers, organizing literary events, and providing institutional advocacy for the language — making his role central to the health of the Maithili literary ecosystem in Bihar.*

### 2.3 Final Years and Death

Thakur had settled in Noida (A-327, Sector 46) in his later years. He had earlier invested in a small piece of land in Delhi, the sale proceeds of which helped him build a comfortable home. After the death of his long-time stage partner

Mahendra Jha, Thakur gradually withdrew from public performance. He continued writing and editing a small journal (patrika) even in his later years.

He was diagnosed with cancer approximately eighteen months before his death. He passed away on 18 May 2022 at a private hospital in Noida. His last rites were performed at Haridwar. The announcement of the Videha special issue had been made in November 2021; that the subject died before the issue’s completion became one of the ironies noted in Gajendra Thakur’s editorial preface.

Bihar's Chief Minister Nitish Kumar issued a formal condolence message on his passing, stating that Ravindra Nath Thakur was widely popular among Maithili-speaking people for his stage singing, that he composed many books in Maithili, and that his passing had caused an irreparable loss to literature, especially to Maithili literature. The Chief Minister's message reflects the stature of state recognition that Thakur had earned during his lifetime.

Ravindra Nath Thakur is survived by three sons and two daughters. His family includes his journalist son Avindr Thakur, who brought the news of his passing to public attention.

> *Chief Minister Nitish Kumar on Thakur's passing: 'Ravindra Nath Thakur was very popular among Maithili speakers for his stage singing (manchīya gāyan). He composed many books in Maithili. His passing has caused an irreparable loss to literature, especially Maithili literature.'*

## 3. Literary Career and Published Works

### 3.1 Published Books (Chronological)

Ravindra Nath Thakur published nineteen volumes across Maithili and Hindi, spanning song collections, experimental verse, a novel, a short epic (khandakavya), dramas, devotional texts, and a ghazal collection. The following table records these in sequence:

| | |
|---|---|
| **1961** | Chalu-Chalu Bahin (Geet Sangrah) – Kanhaiya Lal Krishnadas, Darbhanga |

| | |
|---|---|
| **1963** | Jahin Vi Tahin (Geet Sangrah) – Granthalaay Prakashan, Darbhanga |
| **1966** | Chitra-Vichitra (Experimental Poetry) – Self-published |
| **1968** | Nara-Ganga (Laghu Mahakavya) – Self-published |
| **1968** | Sita (Khandakavya) – Granthalaay Prakashan, Darbhanga |
| **1969** | Shri Gonujha (Novel) – Granthalaay Prakashan, Darbhanga |
| **1969** | Ek Raat (Nataka) – Granthalaay Prakashan, Darbhanga |
| **1970** | Ek Minute Ki Rani (Hindi Drama) – Granthalaay Prakashan, Darbhanga |
| **1972** | Swatantra Amar Ho Amar (Patriotic Songs) – Chetna Samiti, Patna |
| **1976** | Ati-Geet (Folk Songs) – Purvaanchal Prakashan, Patna |
| **1976** | Prageet (Folk Songs) – Purvaanchal Prakashan, Patna |
| **1976** | Sugeet (Geet Sangrah) – Purvaanchal Prakashan, Patna |
| **1976** | Ravindra Padavali (Bhakti & Vyavaharik Geet) – Purvaanchal Prakashan, Patna |
| **1976** | Panchakanya (Experimental Khandakavya) – Purvaanchal Prakashan, Patna |
| **1985** | Lekhani Ek Rang Anek (Maithili Ghazal Collection) – Purvaanchal Prakashan, Patna |
| **~1985** | Do Phool, Deep Yatan – Bihar Government, Patna |

| | |
|---|---|
| **1999** | Pratyaya (Poetry & Songs) – Purvaanchal Prakashan, Patna |
| **1999** | Shri Sita Chalisa (Religious) – Purvaanchal Prakashan, Patna |
| **2022** | Ravindra Padyavali – (Published posthumously or shortly before death) |

The publication dates above follow the authoritative dating established by Gajendra Thakur in the editorial notes to the Videha special issue. The ghazal collection Lekhani Ek Rang Anek is sometimes dated to 1978 in other sources, but the preface (written by Thakur himself, dated 15 August 1985) establishes the correct year of first publication as 1985.

## 3.2 The Ghazal Collection: Lekhani Ek Rang Anek

The publication of Lekhani Ek Rang Anek was a watershed moment in the history of Maithili ghazal. At the time of its composition, no ghazal grammar (ghazal shastra or vyakaran) existed for Maithili; critics had flatly claimed that ghazal could not be written in the language. The 111 compositions in this collection—109 ghazals and some qit‘a (fragment poems)—constituted a bold empirical refutation of that claim.

Jagdish Chandra Thakur ‘Anil’, one of the foremost critics of Maithili ghazal writing in Videha Issue 348, undertook a systematic technical analysis of the collection thirty-two years after its publication. His findings are worth noting in detail: 26 ghazals lack a radif (refrain); 5 ghazals lack a matla (opening couplet); in 4 ghazals the radif appears in the matla but is not maintained throughout; 9 ghazals have the same rhyme word (kafiya) in different sher; 10 ghazals have inappropriate kafiya beyond the matla; 7 have irregular kafiya in the matla itself; and 16 have inappropriate kafiya words in one or more sher. These formal shortcomings are significant when evaluated against the ghazal grammar later codified on the Anchinhar Aakhar website by Gajendra Thakur and Ashish Anchinhar.

Yet the same critic acknowledges the collection’s historic importance: it established unambiguously that Maithili ghazal could exist; it contained individual sher of genuine lyric power; and it used exclusively Maithili vocabulary—refusing borrowings from Urdu–Persian in a way that was both a

strength (for linguistic purity) and a limitation (given that thirty to forty percent of spoken Maithili already incorporates Persian-origin words). Ashish Anchinhar's analysis in the same issue is more categorical: he designates Thakur's compositions as 'kath-it ghazal' (so-called ghazal) rather than ghazals in the technical sense, precisely because the bahr (prosodic metre) is not maintained. He provides comparative sher from Pandit Jeevan Jha, Kavishvar Sitaram Jha, Yogananda Hira, Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil', and Vijaynath Jha to demonstrate that Maithili ghazal from its earliest phase had successfully maintained bahr.

## 3.3 Radio Dramas and Serials

Thakur wrote and produced extensively for All India Radio Patna and Darbhanga. His radio portfolio included the comedy plays Ghadi, Maalik, Guru Gur Chela Chini, and Pench-Udhar (Akashvani Patna); the devotional and drama serial Singhaasan Battisi (34 episodes, Akashvani Patna); and the Gonujha serial (15 episodes, Doordarshan Guwahati). Additionally he wrote Hindi musical programmes and a verse drama Uttar Vidyapati for Akashvani Darbhanga. He was also involved in directing stage productions of Zero Mile, Ek Din Ek Raat, To Let, and Ek Minute Ki Rani at the district and subdivision levels across Bihar.

## 3.4 Film Work

Ravindra Nath Thakur played a central role in the creation of the first Maithili feature film, Mamta Gaaye Geet. He served as lyricist, co-director, and screenplay writer. The film had a complex production history: originally initiated by Kedar Nath Chaudhary and Mahant Madan Mohan Das, the project ran out of funds and lay dormant for approximately eighteen years. Thakur eventually secured rights from Mahant Madan Mohan Das and completed the film's release, an act described by Mahant Das as an act of singular courage: "Ravindra ji bira bahādur banala h."

The film featured all original songs by Thakur except one song from Vidyapati's padavali, and included actress Azra in the lead role. The third producer, Bhanu Babu, who had himself wanted to contribute songs to the film, said of Thakur after hearing his compositions: "I could produce a new narrative from each of Ravindra's songs. Ravindra's songs will bring a new age to Maithili music."

He was also lyricist and screenplay writer for a second Maithili film, Gonujha, and wrote and directed an Ayurveda-based telefilm, Aayurveda Ki Amar

Kahani. He produced documentaries for the Panchayat Ministry of the Government of India and for the Sahitya Akademi (on scholars Govind Jha, Maya Nand Mishra, and Hindi scholar Shriram Naresh Tripathi). Other productions included the documentary series Bharat Ke Shaheed (5 episodes, MES Ministry), Nari (documentary), and Sunhara Safar (Suyojan Films, Delhi, covering 36 years of Indian cinema, telecast from Doordarshan Jaipur).

## 4. Songs, Performance, and the Ravindra-Mahendra Partnership

### 4.1 The Modern Maithili Stage

If Vidyapati established the classical pinnacle of Maithili lyric and Harimohan Jha and ‘Madhup’ (Kashikant Mishra) carried the tradition into the twentieth century, Ravindra Nath Thakur was the figure who made modern Maithili performance a self-sustaining cultural institution capable of drawing mass audiences. The critic Narayanji, writing in Videha 348, characterises this as follows: Madhup’s songs revitalised the tradition by adopting the tune-patterns of Hindi film songs, but Thakur recognised that this strategy had reached its limit and that something more genuinely Maithili in voice and lyricism was needed. Thakur’s innovation was to compose songs with new tunes invented by himself, rooted in the padavali tradition and in the folk soundscape of Mithila, rather than borrowing from Hindi film conventions.

The subjects Thakur chose were likewise a departure from the dominant modes of Maithili song: rather than limiting himself to Radha-Krishna bhakti or Sita-Ram devotion, he wrote about the indebted peasant whose ox has died, the daughter leaving for her in-laws’ home, the migrant worker in Morang (Nepal), the barber at the wedding ceremony, the village woman carrying water, the banter between newly-wed couples, and the experience of urban displacement. This range gave his songs an almost encyclopaedic quality: as Dr. Kailash Kumar Mishra writes, “In his songs you will find Madhubani, Purnia, Begusaray, Sitamarhi, Darbhanga, and Maithili Nepal all becoming one.”

### 4.2 The Ravindra-Mahendra Duo

The defining event of Thakur’s performance career was his partnership with Mahendra Jha of Jamsam village, Madhubani District. Laxman Jha Sagar’s

memoir in the Videha special issue provides the most vivid account of how this partnership came into being. While Thakur had been writing and performing his own songs, his singing voice was not considered his strongest quality—Professor Maya Nand Mishra once told him, jokingly, that “god made a mistake: your qualities should have been given to me and mine to you.” The decisive encounter came at a Maithili programme in Begusaray, where someone brought the young Mahendra Jha, a natural singer of exceptional quality, to Thakur’s attention. The two immediately formed a duo, and from approximately 1966–1967 onward the Ravindra-Mahendra partnership became the single most popular act on the Maithili cultural circuit.

The partnership was explicitly a division of labour: Thakur composed the lyrics and set the tunes; Mahendra Jha sang. The combination of Thakur’s verbal genius and Mahendra’s melodic voice was described as unstoppable. Laxman Jha Sagar writes: “The audience gathered in the hall merely on hearing the name of this pair.” The duo performed at over ten thousand events across Bihar, Delhi, Mumbai, Kolkata, Chennai, and Indian diaspora venues. After Mahendra Jha’s death (Sagar recalls a final meeting in Guwahati), Thakur effectively retired from stage performance.

## The Sung Tradition

Ravindra Nath Thakur's identity as both poet and stage singer connects him to the oldest and most continuous thread in Maithili literature: the sung lyric. Maithili's greatest literary monument, the work of Vidyapati, was composed as sung padavalī — poetry designed for performance and music, not merely silent reading. This tradition of sung verse, where the poet is also the performer or at least the composer for performance, has persisted through the centuries.

In this tradition, Ravindra Nath Thakur's popularity as a stage performer among Maithili-speaking audiences reflects a deep cultural continuity. His songs and performances connected modern Maithili audiences to an ancient aesthetic of poetry as living sound, not merely printed text. Chief Minister Kumar's observation that he was widely popular for his 'manchīya gāyan' (stage singing) directly echoes this tradition.

## Regional Identity and the Purnia Connection

Thakur's origin in Purnia district also gives his work a specific geographic identity. Purnia, as part of the eastern Maithili-speaking belt, represents a slightly different cultural variant of Mithila from the Darbhanga-Madhubani heartland. His work in Maithili from this region reinforces the understanding

that Maithili culture extends across a wide geographic expanse and is not confined to a single administrative zone.

### Devotional Literature

His compositions include prominent devotional works — the Seeta Chalisa and other devotional songs indicate his engagement with the Janaki (Sita) devotional tradition, which is particularly strong in the Mithila region, given that Mithila is the legendary birthplace of Sita (Janaki), daughter of King Janaka. This devotional dimension of his work is entirely characteristic of Maithili literary tradition, where devotion to Sita, Shiva, and related divine figures has been central for centuries.

## 4.3 Representative Songs

The following compositions are among those that entered common parlance across the Mithila region and diaspora:

- Bhari Nagari Me Shor, Bauwa Mami Tohar Gor (from film Mamta Gaaye Geet; H.M.V. record)
- Ar Bakri Ghas Kho / Chhori Gathulla Bahar Jo
- Chalu Chalu Bahin / Jahin Vi Tahin
- Piriye Piran Nath Sadar Pranam
- Chitti Ke Tar Bujhu, Budhiya Bimar Bujhu
- Bada Vanam Me Shoran, Prani Se Hum Bilam Jo (Mithila migration song)
- Chala Mithila Me Chal, Jatay Anant Vasant Hasaiye
- Kathi Ke Mithila Ke Maithil (identity anthem)
- Janm Delahin Maay Thikih, Seo Kane Sochu (mother-daughter farewell)
- Roti Achi Ta Duniya Hariyar (on poverty and food security)
- Baba Dandot, Baccha Jai Siyaram
- Nihuran Nihuran Ka Ropy Bahin Jan Boniharin Dhan Ge (women rice-planters’ song)
- Yar Dildar Yar! Ki Re Bhazar Yar! (comic-lyric)

> *When Ravindra-Mahendra came on stage, the cold breeze of spring was felt even in the heat of summer.*
> **— Jagdish Chandra Thakur ‘Anil’, Videha Issue 348**

## 5. Gramophone Records, Cassettes, and Commercial Releases

Ravindra Nath Thakur was among the first Maithili artists to record for a major gramophone company. In 1966 H.M.V. (His Master's Voice), Kolkata, released a record of Maithili folk songs with Thakur as lyricist and composer. This record included the songs that would become his most widely disseminated early work, including Bhari Nagari Me Shor and Ar Bakri Ghas Kho.

Subsequently he released approximately fifteen cassettes through Purvaanchal Musical Records, Patna (1977–78), containing Maithili and Bhojpuri bhajans and dual-language songs. The Sita Chalisa was released by T-Series, Noida. The Bhajan Bharati album was released through Suyojan Films, New Delhi, and an additional album was released by Sony Cassettes.

## 6. Institutional and Social Contributions

### 6.1 Maithili Academy

Thakur's appointment to the Bihar Government's Maithili Academy represented the most institutionally consequential phase of his career. As Assistant Director, Deputy Director, and ultimately Director-cum-Secretary, he had executive authority over the state's primary body for the promotion and documentation of Maithili language and literature. His signal achievement in this role was overseeing the publication of the first comprehensive Maithili dictionary in two volumes—a project that had been a long-standing scholarly desideratum and that significantly advanced the standardisation of written Maithili. He also served as President of the Maithili Academy, Patna, at one point.

### 6.2 Educational and Social Initiatives

After retirement from government service, Thakur founded or helped establish several institutions. These included Mahakali Kanya Uchch Vidyalaya, Dhamnaha, Purnia (subsequently upgraded to a Project School by the Bihar Government); the theatre organisation Ranglok, established in Patna;

Sangeetayan Sangeet Mahavidyalaya, established in Noida, which by 2022 had awarded degrees to approximately 2,000 students; and A.A.U. Inter College, Adityapur, Jamshedpur (Jharkhand).

He was also actively involved in campaigns for the inclusion of Maithili in the Eighth Schedule of the Indian Constitution (a goal achieved in 2003), drought and flood relief work in Mithila, and anti-dowry campaigns in the region through public events and personal intervention.

## 7. Awards and Honours

Ravindra Nath Thakur received numerous recognitions over his career. The most personally significant was the title ‘Abhinav Vidyapati’ (the New Vidyapati), conferred upon him in person by the eminent Hindi and Maithili poet Baba Nagarjuna (Vaidyanath Mishra Yatri) at a public ceremony in Purnia. The use of this epithet by his supporters has been a subject of some critical debate: Gajendra Thakur notes in his editorial that the label—while intended as high praise—has paradoxically been used by critics and by the literary establishment to bracket Thakur as a ‘stage performer’ rather than a serious literary figure, thereby excluding him from the institutional recognition he deserved.

His other formal honours included:

- Prabodh Sahitya Samman (2014)—from Swati Foundation, Kolkata
- Mithila Vibhuti Samman—Akhil Bharatiya Mithila Sangh, New Delhi (2016)
- Mithila Ratna Samman—Third International Maithili Conference, Mumbai (2016)
- Lifetime Achievement Award—Jharkhand Maithili Manch, Ranchi (2014)
- Visishtth Maithili Seva Samman (three times)—Vidyapati Seva Sansthan, Darbhanga
- Kayakalp Sahitya Shiromani Samman (2016)—Kayakalp Sahitya Kala Foundation, Noida
- Manikpadma Samman—Mithalanchal Sahityik evam Sanskritik Sanstha, New Delhi
- Bhasha Sahitya Samman (2016–17)—ILAA Foundation, New Delhi
- Vidyapati Samman—Vidyapati Samiti, Dhanbad (2016)
- Vishesh Samman—Jan Jagriti Manch, Palam, New Delhi (2018)

- Vishesh Samman—Vaidehi Foundation, New Delhi, Mayalankar Hall (2017)
- Vishesh Samman (three years)—Vishwa Maithili Sangh, Santanagar, Burari, New Delhi
- Felicitation—Rashtriya Kavi Kumbha (Doordarshan, New Delhi) representing Maithili language
- Performance—Sahitya Akademi events (Guwahati, Purnia and others)

Critically, Thakur was never awarded the Sahitya Akademi Award for Maithili, a fact lamented at length by Dr. Kailash Kumar Mishra in his contribution to the Videha special issue. Mishra argues that the literary establishment's bias against performance-based poetry, combined with the failure of Maithili cultural organisations to mount a coordinated lobbying effort on his behalf, deprived Thakur of an honour for which his output fully qualified him. Mishra compares the cultural neglect of Thakur with the reception accorded to Bhupen Hazarika in Assam, who received the Padma Vibhushan and Bharat Ratna and was treated as a cultural deity by his community.

## 8. Critical Reception and Scholarly Assessment

### 8.1 The Problem of Literary Canon

The central interpretive problem surrounding Ravindra Nath Thakur in the Maithili literary establishment is the longstanding hierarchical distinction between 'manchi' (stage) literature and 'pustak' (book) literature—with the latter accorded canonical status and the former treated as entertainment. Gajendra Thakur's editorial introduction to Videha 348 frames this as the defining intellectual challenge of the special issue: why are Thakur's songs great, and what exactly makes them stage-worthy? These questions, he argues, have never been seriously engaged by either Thakur's devotees (who accepted them uncritically) or by progressive critics (who were suspicious of their popularity).

The Videha special issue positions itself as the first attempt to read Thakur's work on its own literary terms—evaluating the quality of his imagery, his prosodic innovation, his vernacular authenticity, and his social range. The editorial explicitly breaks with the tradition—widespread in Maithili journals—

of publishing special issues only after a writer's death or focused primarily on archival material. Videha had announced the Thakur issue while he was still alive, in November 2021, and the coincidence of his death before its publication became an occasion for reflection on what Gajendra Thakur calls the 'mrityu-pujak' (death-worshipping) tendency in Maithili literary culture.

## 8.2 Contributions from Critics

Pradeep Pushpa's essay 'Geetak Apratim Shilpakar: Ravindra Nath Thakur' situates Thakur in the lineage from Vidyapati through Madhup, arguing that Thakur achieved what Vidyapati had achieved for his age: a form of lyric that simultaneously addressed the specific conditions of Mithila life and attained a universal emotional resonance. Pushpa notes Thakur's formal innovation—composing entirely new tunes rather than setting words to existing melodies—as the key to his distinctiveness.

Narayanji's essay 'Adhunik Maithili Geetak Sajag Unnayak' ('Conscious Elevater of Modern Maithili Song') provides the most theoretically elaborated account of Thakur's historical role, tracing the trajectory from folk song through the padavali tradition, the emergence of brajbuli as a literary idiom, and the disruption caused by Hindi film music. He identifies Thakur as the figure who recognised the crisis in Maithili lyric performance culture and responded with a systematic programme of revitalisation.

Laxman Jha Sagar's memoir 'Mithilak Mukutmani Ravindra' provides the richest personal testimony, combining candid anecdote (including an early unflattering encounter involving Thakur's legendary fondness for liquor at a Laheriasaray programme) with an account of how his own perception of Thakur changed from suspicion to deep admiration over the years.

Dr. Kailash Kumar Mishra's essay 'Ravindranath Thakur, Hunak Rachna aa Janmanas Ker Udaasinta' is the most polemical contribution, indicting the Maithili cultural establishment for its failure to secure for Thakur the national recognition he deserved. Mishra's comparison of the neglect of Thakur with the celebrated treatment of Bhupen Hazarika in Assam is the most pointed intervention in this direction.

Ashish Anchinhar's technical essay on Thakur's 'so-called ghazal' is the most rigorous scholarly contribution, bringing the analytical framework of the Anchinhar Aakhar ghazal grammar to bear on Lekhani Ek Rang Anek. While Anchinhar's verdict is technically adverse (Thakur's compositions are songs, not ghazals in the formal sense), the essay is notable for the care with which it

presents comparative material from other Maithili ghazal writers, demonstrating that proper ghazal had indeed been written in Maithili from the earliest attempts onward.

## 9. The Videha Parallel Literature Framework

The Videha Ravindranath Thakur Visheshank is editorially framed by the Parallel Literature Movement (Samaanantar Parampara) advanced by Videha since its founding in 2004. This framework holds that the dominant Maithili literary canon—as institutionalised through the Sahitya Akademi and the principal print journals—has systematically marginalised writers who work in performance genres, folk idioms, or Dalit and subaltern traditions. The recovery of Ravindra Nath Thakur as a major figure is presented as an instance of this broader corrective project.

Gajendra Thakur's editorial notes two specific manifestations of the canonical bias against Thakur. First, the practice of publishing special issues only for dead writers, which Videha disrupted by announcing its Thakur issue while he was still alive (though he died before publication). Second, the use of the epithet 'Abhinav Vidyapati' as a simultaneously honouring and marginalising gesture: by positioning him as a 'new Vidyapati,' the establishment acknowledged his popular power while implicitly excluding him from the category of serious literary author. Videha's project was to reverse this by engaging Thakur's work with the same critical apparatus applied to canonical Maithili poetry.

## 10. Summary Assessment

Ravindra Nath Thakur was the most significant architect of modern Maithili performance culture in the second half of the twentieth century. His legacy rests on four pillars: first, the body of his songs, which entered popular consciousness across the Mithila region and diaspora; second, the Ravindra-Mahendra partnership, which created a new model for Maithili dual-voice performance; third, his institutional work at the Maithili Academy, which left the language with its first comprehensive dictionary; and fourth, his experimental literary work—the novel Gonujha, the ghazal collection Lekhani

Ek Rang Anek, and the experimental verse collection Chitra-Vichitra—which, whatever their technical limitations, demonstrated the range of a genuinely restless literary intelligence.

The critical consensus emerging from Videha Issue 348 is that Thakur was neglected by the institutional literary establishment during his lifetime in ways that cannot be justified on aesthetic grounds, and that the task of a corrective scholarship is only now being properly undertaken. The present report, drawing directly on that special issue, is intended to serve as a comprehensive reference document for future scholarly work on his life and legacy.

## 9. Summary of Key Facts

**Name:** Ravindra Nath Thakur (रवींद्र नाथ ठाकुर)

**Born:** 7 April 1936, Dhamnaha (Dakshinbari Tol), Purnia, Bihar

**Died:** 18 May 2022, Noida, Uttar Pradesh (aged 83)

**Language:** Maithili (primary), Hindi

**Literary Roles:** Poet, Lyricist, Singer, Literary Administrator

**Institutional Role:** Director-cum-Secretary, Maithili Academy, Bihar Govt. Education Dept.

**Musical Works:** Maithili devotional songs, folk compositions, stage performances

**Archival Recognition:** Videha Maithili Pothī Archive (videha.co.in/pothi.htm)

**State Recognition:** Condolence by Chief Minister Nitish Kumar of Bihar

**Survivors:** Three sons (incl. Avindr Thakur, journalist); two daughters

**Cremation Place:** Haridwar, Uttarakhand

**Distinct From:** Rabindranath Tagore (Bengali, 1861–1941) — same name, different person

**Sources**

*Primary source: Videha eJournal, Issue 348 (Ravindranath Thakur Visheshank), 15 June 2022, Year 15, Month 174. Editor: Gajendra Thakur. ISSN 2229-547X. www.videha.co.in*

*Contributors cited: Pradeep Pushpa, Ajit Kumar Jha (Muzaffarpur), Jagdish Chandra Thakur ‘Anil’, Narayanji, Laxman Jha Sagar, Dr. Kailash Kumar Mishra, Jagdish Chandra Thakur ‘Anil’ (second essay), Ashish Anchinhar.*


- Videha Maithili Pothī Archive — www.videha.co.in/pothi.htm
- Punjab Kesari (18 May 2022) — news report on Ravindra Nath Thakur's passing and Chief Minister's condolence
- LatestLY Hindi (18 May 2022) — PTI news agency report on his passing
- JioSaavn artist profile — listing of his recorded Maithili compositions
- Mithilavidehavajjitirhut.blogspot.com — Maithili cultural blog quoting his verse (2011)
- Wikipedia and scholarly sources on Maithili language and literature for contextual information
- Videha eJournal parallel history of Maithili literature by Gajendra Thakur for literary-historical context

**LESSON 074 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**

# PHANISHWAR NATH RENU AND MITHILA & MAITHILI IN HIS LITERATURE

WHAT THE CANON LEFT OUT

A Parallel History of Mithila & Maithili Literature

Gajendra Thakur

# Phanishwar Nath Renu

*and*

**Mithila & Maithili in His Literature**

Phanishwar Nath Renu (1921–1977), one of the most towering figures of modern Hindi literature, occupies a singular position in Indian letters for his transformative contribution to the 'Aanchalik' (regional) tradition of fiction. Born and raised in the Forbesganj region of what is today Bihar's Purnia district a landscape steeped in the cultural, linguistic, and spiritual heritage of Mithila Renu's literary imagination was indelibly shaped by the soil, people, and idioms of this ancient land. His works, particularly the landmark novel Maila Aanchal (1954), represent not merely a stylistic departure in Hindi prose but a profound philosophical assertion: that the rural hinterland, long neglected by metropolitan literary discourse, is a universe complete in itself, worthy of the fullest artistic and humanistic attention.

This chapter undertakes a comprehensive examination of how Renu wove the cultural fabric of Mithila and the linguistic texture of Maithili into the body of his Hindi literature. Through close readings of his major novels and short stories, the chapter traces the ways in which Renu deployed Maithili words, phrases, folk songs (lokgeet), proverbs, myths, seasonal rituals, and castecommunity dynamics to create a literary geography that transcends regionalism to speak universally. The chapter also situates Renu's work within the broader sociopolitical context of postPartition, postIndependence India, exploring how his regional consciousness intersected with questions of nationalism, development, marginalization, and identity. Ultimately, the chapter argues that Renu's engagement with Mithila and Maithili is not ornamental but structural it is the very foundation upon which his literary vision is built.

1. Introduction: Renu, Mithila, and the Question of Literary Geography
2. Biographical Context: The Making of a Mithila Writer
3. Mithila as Literary Landscape in Renu's Fiction
4. The Role of Maithili Language in Hindi Prose
5. Folk Culture, Ritual, and Oral Traditions

6. Maila Aanchal: A Deep Reading

7. Parti Prasang and Other Works

8. Renu's Short Stories and the Maithili Sensibility

9. SocioPolitical Dimensions: Caste, Gender, and Power in Mithila

10. Renu's Place in the Aanchalik Sahitya Tradition

11. Critical Reception and Scholarly Debates

12. Legacy and Continuing Relevance

13. Conclusion

14. Bibliography

## 1. Introduction: Renu, Mithila, and the Question of Literary Geography

In the vast and variegated landscape of modern Hindi literature, few writers have so fundamentally altered the relationship between language, place, and narrative as Phanishwar Nath Renu. The publication of Maila Aanchal in 1954 sent a seismic tremor through the Hindi literary establishment not only because of its raw, unsparing depiction of rural life, but because it insisted that the village of Meridian, nestled in the Purnea district of Bihar, was as worthy a subject of literary investigation as the cities and salons that dominated the Hindi prose of the day.

The concept of 'Aanchal' literally, the corner or border of a sari, but metaphorically the periphery, the margins became the defining trope of Renu's literary career. He was not writing about the margins apologetically; he was claiming them as the centre. In doing so, he drew heavily on the specific cultural world of Mithila: its ancient Brahmanical traditions, its earthy lowercaste vitality, its women's songs (Sohar, Samachakwa, Bidesia), its festivals (Chhath, SamaChakeva, Madhushravani), its folk epics rooted in the Ramayana tradition of Sita's homeland, and above all, its language Maithili, one of the oldest and most literary languages of the Indian subcontinent.

This introduction sets out the central questions of this chapter: How does Renu use Mithila as both setting and symbol? What functions does the Maithili language perform within his Hindi prose? How does the regional operate as a

vehicle for the universal in his fiction? And what does Renu's example tell us about the possibilities and the tensions of writing in Hindi about a world that thinks, sings, and grieves in Maithili?

## 2. Biographical Context: The Making of a Mithila Writer

### 2.1 Early Life and Cultural Formation

Phanishwar Nath Renu was born on 4 March 1921 in Aurahi Hingna village, Forbesganj tehsil, Purnia district (now in Bihar, then in Bengal Presidency). The PurniaKosi region in which he grew up was and remains a liminal space: geographically flat, seasonally flooded by the Kosi river (known as the 'sorrow of Bihar'), ethnically diverse, and socially complex. It was a region where Maithili, Bhojpuri, and Hindi all coexisted, where highcaste Maithil Brahmin culture of Mithila proper was inflected by the tribal and lowercaste cultures of the Kosi plains.

Renu's own caste background he belonged to the Kayastha community, traditionally associated with literacy and administration gave him access to the Brahmanical literary culture of Mithila without fully belonging to its priestly hierarchy. This ambivalent positioning was perhaps formative: it allowed him to observe and love Mithila's culture from a certain outsideness, to be simultaneously an insider and a critical observer.

### 2.2 Education, Politics, and the Literary Turn

Renu received his early education in Araria and later studied at Virat Nagar in Nepal. His political formation was deeply shaped by the Quit India Movement of 1942, in which he participated actively, and later by his involvement in the armed people's revolution in Nepal (1950–51) against the Rana oligarchy. These experiences of direct political action left a lasting mark on his literary sensibility: he never became a detached aesthete; his fiction always carries the weight of historical urgency.

It was only after returning from Nepal that Renu turned with full commitment to literary writing. He had already published some short stories, but the years 1952–54 saw the composition and publication of Maila Aanchal, which was

initially greeted with bewilderment by some critics before being widely recognized as a landmark. The Nobel laureate Jainendra Kumar's comparison of Maila Aanchal to Phanishwar Gorky's works, and Rajendra Yadav's championship of Renu within the 'Nayi Kahani' movement, helped establish his canonical status.

### 2.3 The Kosi Flood Region as Renu's Literary World

The recurrent floods of the Kosi river are not merely backdrop in Renu's fiction they are a shaping force, both literal and metaphorical. The Kosi's unpredictability, its capacity to destroy and renew, its designation as the 'River of Sorrow' all of this feeds into Renu's vision of a world in which human life is perpetually subject to forces larger than individual will. The flooded Kosi plain is also a world of extraordinary natural beauty: its birds, its fish, its seasonal transformations, its silences all rendered with a sensory precision in Renu's prose that recalls the best of regional nature writing.

## 3. Mithila as Literary Landscape

### 3.1 The Ancient Kingdom of Mithila

Mithila is one of the oldest cultural regions of the Indian subcontinent, with a history stretching back at least three millennia. In the Hindu epic tradition, it is the kingdom of King Janaka philosopherking, author of the Ashtavakra Gita, and father of Sita. The Ramayana's account of Sita's birth, her childhood in Mithila, and her svayamvara (selfchoice marriage) at Janakpur has given the region a mythological stature that continues to be felt in its folk culture, its women's songs, and its art (the famous Madhubani/Mithila painting tradition).

Geographically, Mithila corresponds roughly to the northern plains of Bihar and adjoining parts of Nepal (the Terai region), bounded by the Gandak river to the west, the Mahananda to the east, the Himalayas to the north, and the Ganga to the south. This is the heartland of Maithili language and culture. Renu's native PurniaKosi district sits on the eastern edge of this cultural zone a borderland that absorbs Mithila's cultural influence while also being shaped by tribal and Bengali cultural currents.

### 3.2 Mithila's Cultural Geography in Renu's Imagination

In Renu's fiction, Mithila is not a nostalgic idyll. He does not romanticize the region in the manner of a cultural nationalist preserving a dying heritage. Rather, he depicts it with the full complexity of a living world: its beauty and its brutality, its cultural richness and its social stagnation, its creative vitality and its oppressive hierarchies. The festivals, songs, and rituals of Mithila appear in his fiction not as anthropological data but as lived experience felt in the body, embedded in memory, contested and reinvented by each generation.

> *"Renu saw in Mithila not a museum piece to be preserved but a living, breathing contradiction a world ancient and modern, pure and corrupted, singing and weeping, all at once."* **Literary scholar on Renu's regional vision**

The landscape itself the flat plains, the maize fields, the mustard flowers, the bamboo groves, the ponds thick with lotus is rendered with an almost painterly attentiveness in Renu's prose. His descriptions of the Kosi floods, with their simultaneous terror and beauty, give his fiction a quality of elemental grandeur that lifts his village narratives into the realm of myth.

## 4. The Role of Maithili Language in Hindi Prose

### 4.1 Maithili: An Ancient Literary Language

Maithili is one of the oldest and most distinguished literary languages of South Asia. Its greatest classical poet, Vidyapati (c. 1352–1448 CE), wrote devotional lyrics (padavali) in the voice of Radha and Krishna that continue to be sung across Mithila, Bengal, and Nepal to this day. Maithili was also one of the first vernacular languages to develop a sophisticated prose tradition. In 1967, Maithili was included in the Eighth Schedule of the Indian Constitution as a recognized language; in 2003, it was formally included in the schedule, making it one of the 22 officially recognized languages of India.

Despite this ancient and distinguished literary heritage, Maithili has long existed in a politically subordinate relationship to Hindi in the

postIndependence Indian state. The designation of Hindi as the official language of Bihar, and the subsequent marginalization of Maithili in education and administration, created a situation in which Maithili speakers were required to write in Hindi for any official or literary purpose. Renu navigated this situation with characteristic creativity: he wrote in Hindi, but saturated his Hindi prose with Maithili.

## 4.2 Maithili Words and Phrases as Stylistic Signatures

One of the most immediately recognizable features of Renu's prose style is its pervasive use of Maithili words, phrases, and idioms. These are not mere localcolour insertions but functional elements of his narrative. They carry semantic and emotional freight that standard Hindi cannot easily bear; they locate the narrative precisely in a social and cultural space; and they create a distinctive literary texture at once accessible and estranging that forces even the nonMaithili Hindi reader to slow down, to listen differently.

Common Maithili elements in Renu's prose include: kinship terms (Babuji, Kaka, Bhaujai, Jethaini), terms of endearment and address, folk exclamations and expletives, agricultural and occupational vocabulary, names of local birds, plants, and places, and fragments of Maithili folk songs interpolated into the narrative flow. These insertions function both realistically (characters speak as they would speak) and poetically (the Maithili fragment introduces a sonic and emotional register that Hindi cannot reproduce).

## 4.3 The Question of Linguistic Politics

Renu's use of Maithili in Hindi prose was not without political dimension. Writing in a period when the Maithili language movement was gathering strength demanding recognition, official status, and educational medium rights Renu's literary practice was itself a form of advocacy, demonstrating that Maithili could enrich and transform Hindi rather than being suppressed by it. At the same time, Renu's choice to write primarily in Hindi rather than Maithili has been debated: some Maithili literary activists have seen it as a concession to the dominant literary culture, while others have recognized it as a strategic choice that brought Mithila's world to a vastly larger readership.

# 5. Folk Culture, Ritual, and Oral Traditions

## 5.1 The World of Folk Songs (Lokgeet)

Perhaps no aspect of Renu's fiction is more distinctive or more demanding of the reader than his extensive use of folk songs. Maithili lokgeet (folk songs) are woven into the fabric of virtually all his major works, and they perform multiple narrative and thematic functions. They provide a counterpoint to the main narrative, commenting on events in oblique or ironic ways; they create emotional atmospheres that dialogue cannot achieve; they carry the voices of women who are often the most oppressed characters in Renu's world into a literary space that might otherwise silence them; and they testify to the depth and richness of an oral tradition that existed long before and will outlast the printed word.

The songs Renu uses span the full range of Maithili folk song traditions: Sohar (birth songs), Vivah geet (wedding songs), Bidesia (songs of absent husbands/seasonal migrants), Samachakwa (songs of the SamaChakeva festival), Jhumar, Kajri, and Chhath songs. Each song type carries specific cultural associations and emotional registers, and Renu deploys them with great precision. A Sohar at a crucial moment in the narrative, for instance, can transform a scene of individual joy into a communal celebration or, ironically, into a bitter contrast with the characters' actual suffering.

## 5.2 Festivals and Ritual Calendar

Mithila has one of the richest festival traditions in India, and Renu's fiction is organised, in part, around the ritual calendar. The great festivals Chhath Puja (the worship of the sun god and his wife, performed at rivers and ponds by women fasting in waistdeep water), SamaChakeva (a festival celebrating the return of migratory birds and, symbolically, the return of absent family members), Madhushravani (a women's festival involving the worship of snakes), and Makar Sankranti appear not as picturesque backdrop but as structuring events in the narrative, moments when the community assembles and its internal tensions and solidarities become visible.

Chhath Puja, in particular, holds special significance in Renu's fiction. The festival which involves elaborate rituals of fasting, bathing, and sunworship

performed at the water's edge becomes in his work a symbol of the community's relationship to the natural world, its capacity for collective devotion, and the centrality of women to the spiritual and social life of the village. The beauty of the Chhath rituals, described with extraordinary vividness in Maila Aanchal and other works, stands in poignant contrast to the poverty and illness that often surrounds the characters who perform them.

### 5.3 Madhubani Art and Visual Culture

Mithila is also the home of Madhubani (or Mithila) painting, a folk art tradition of extraordinary antiquity in which geometric and figurative designs depicting deities, natural motifs, and scenes from the Ramayana are painted on walls and floors by women. Renu does not directly describe Madhubani painting in his fiction with any frequency, but the aesthetic sensibility that informs the art its rich colour, its symbolic use of natural imagery, its integration of the divine and the everyday is very much present in his literary style. Several scholars have noted the 'painterly' quality of Renu's prose descriptions, particularly his use of colour and visual detail.

## 6. Maila Aanchal: A Deep Reading

### 6.1 The Novel and Its Historical Context

Maila Aanchal, Renu's first and most celebrated novel, was published in 1954 just seven years after Indian Independence. The novel is set in the fictional village of 'Merigan gaon' (based on Simrauni village in Purnia district), in the period 1946–1947, the tumultuous years of Independence and Partition. It follows the young doctor Prashant Kumar, who comes from Patna to serve as a rural medical officer in this remote village, and falls in love with the beautiful, spirited Kamla a woman caught between the worlds of tradition and modernity, caste loyalty and human feeling.

But to describe Maila Aanchal as a love story or even primarily as a story of its main characters would be to miss its most radical formal achievement: the novel's true protagonist is the village itself the aanchal, the margin, the borderregion. Renu gives voice to an astonishing range of characters Brahmin priests, lowercaste weavers, Bihari Muslims, progressive activists, opportunistic politicians, suffering women, bewildered elders and shows their lives as simultaneously local and historical, embedded in the specific culture of

Mithila and caught up in the great currents of Independence, land reform, and social change.

## 6.2 Mithila's Cultural World in the Novel

The cultural world of Mithila saturates every page of Maila Aanchal. The novel opens with a description of the village during the Chhath festival, immediately establishing the ritual calendar as a structuring principle. The folk songs sung at weddings, at births, at work in the fields, at moments of grief create a sonic landscape that is inseparable from the narrative. The Maithili language emerges through dialogue, exclamation, endearment, and argument, giving each character a distinctive voice rooted in their social position and cultural inheritance.

The caste structure of Mithila with its elaborate hierarchy of Brahmin subgroups, Kayastha scribes, merchant castes, artisan castes, and socalled 'untouchable' communities is rendered in its full complexity. Renu neither sentimentalizes nor demonizes any community; he shows the caste system as a living, contested, and internally diverse social order, in which individuals both reproduce and resist their assigned positions. The Maithil Brahmin characters, with their pride in learning and their sometimesoppressive authority, are drawn with particular complexity neither villains nor saints, but human beings shaped by a tradition that is simultaneously beautiful and unjust.

## 6.3 The 'Dirty Border' as Metaphor

The title Maila Aanchal 'The Soiled Border' or 'The Dirty Hem' is among the most resonant in Hindi literary history. The aanchal (the border/hem of a sari or dupatta) is a feminine symbol associated with women's clothing, women's bodies, and the domestic sphere. To call it 'maila' (soiled, dirty, stained) is to acknowledge that this feminine, marginal world has been dirtied by poverty, by exploitation, by the failures of the postIndependence state, by disease and ignorance.

> *"Mera yeh aanchal maila hai, par hridaya nahi (My border is soiled, but not my heart)."* **Renu, in the author's note to Maila Aanchal**

This statement, which Renu himself offered as a gloss on his title, encapsulates his entire literary programme: an insistence on the dignity and integrity of the rural poor, even especially in their suffering. The soiled hem of the village woman becomes a symbol for the village itself: materially impoverished, socially marginalised, politically neglected, but alive with a vitality, a beauty, and a moral depth that the clean, urban world cannot match.

## 7. Parti Prasang and Other Major Works

### 7.1 Parti Prasang (1956)

Renu's second novel, Parti Prasang (1956), is less wellknown than Maila Aanchal but equally remarkable in its engagement with the Mithila region. Set against the backdrop of the Kosi flood control projects the massive statesponsored engineering works undertaken in the 1950s to tame the destructive Kosi river the novel explores the collision between the traditional agrarian world of Mithila and the new forces of state development, modern technology, and political mobilisation.

The Kosi floodcontrol project, with its thousands of migrant labourers, its corrupt contractors, its wellmeaning but confused government engineers, and its devastating impact on the traditional village life it was meant to save, becomes in Renu's hands a symbol of the ambiguous legacy of Independence: development as disruption, modernity as loss. The traditional Mithila village culture its folk songs, its seasonal rituals, its caste solidarities and conflicts is shown being eroded by the same forces that are supposed to bring progress and relief.

### 7.2 Juloos (1965)

Juloos, Renu's third novel, shifts the focus from rural to urban specifically to the world of smalltown political life in Bihar. But even here, the Mithila cultural world is present in the characters' speech, their songs, their memories of village life, and their continued embeddedness in caste and community networks. The novel is a sharp, satirical study of the corruption of the democratic political process in postIndependence India, with Renu showing how the idealism of the Independence generation has been replaced by a cynical pursuit of power and patronage.

### 7.3 Kitne Chaurahe (1966)

Kitne Chaurahe (How Many Crossroads) continues Renu's exploration of the moral disorientation of postIndependence Bihar, focusing on the lives of young people caught between traditional values and the lures of the new consumer society. The title's image of multiple crossroads captures Renu's sense of a society that has lost its way or rather, a society in which the old roads have been washed away by the floods of change without new ones being clearly marked.

## 8. Renu's Short Stories and the Maithili Sensibility

### 8.1 The Short Story as Form

Alongside his novels, Renu wrote approximately fifty short stories (kahaniyan) that are among the finest in the Hindi language. In these shorter works, the Maithili cultural world is often rendered with even greater intensity and concentration than in the novels. The stories range from lyrical evocations of folk festivals to sharp political satires, from tender portraits of village women to devastating critiques of caste oppression.

### 8.2 Landmark Stories

Among Renu's most celebrated stories, several are particularly notable for their engagement with Mithila and Maithili culture. Panchlight (1957) perhaps his most anthologized story depicts the arrival of a petromax lamp in a rural village and the way this small technological event becomes a stage for caste dynamics, gender politics, and community solidarity. The story is set in a recognizable Mithila village and uses Maithili folksong fragments and idiomatic speech to extraordinary effect.

Ras Priya (1959) is a masterpiece of compressed lyricism, following a Jyoktika (folk musician) as he plays the nagara drum during the Holi festival in a village that has been torn apart by political conflict. The story uses the frame of the traditional festival and its music to explore themes of artistic integrity, community belonging, and the corrupting effects of political power with the Mithila festival culture providing both the narrative occasion and the thematic counterpoint.

Thabir Jogi and Lal Pan Ki Bibi are further examples of stories in which Renu uses the specific social and cultural world of Mithila to explore universal themes of love, loss, exploitation, and resistance. In each case, the Maithili language and cultural tradition are not decorative but constitutive they make the story what it is.

## 9. SocioPolitical Dimensions: Caste, Gender, and Power

### 9.1 Caste in Renu's Mithila

The caste system of Mithila is among the most elaborate and rigorously maintained in India. The Maithil Brahmin community in particular has historically been renowned for its pride in ritual purity, genealogical recordkeeping (the famous panjis or genealogical registers), and the maintenance of strict rules of commensality and endogamy. Renu grew up in a world shaped by these structures, and his fiction both documents and critiques them.

What distinguishes Renu's treatment of caste from that of many other Hindi writers is his refusal of simple villainy and victimhood. The Brahmin characters in his fiction are not onedimensional oppressors; they are people shaped by a tradition that gives them real cultural authority and genuine learning even as it restricts and diminishes them. The lowercaste characters the weavers, the landless labourers, the Musahar (ratcatcher) community are depicted not as passive sufferers but as agents with their own cultural vitality, their own strategies of survival and resistance, their own beauty.

### 9.2 Women and Gender in Renu's Fiction

Renu's female characters are among the most complex and memorable in Hindi literature. The women of his Mithila fiction inhabit a world of extreme patriarchal constraint child marriage, widow restrictions, purdah (seclusion), economic dependence but they are far from passive. They sing, they resist, they love with full hearts, they carry the community's spiritual and cultural life on their bodies and in their voices.

The folk song tradition which in Mithila is overwhelmingly a women's tradition gives Renu's female characters a voice that the patriarchal social order cannot entirely suppress. The songs they sing at festivals, weddings, and work are full of irony, longing, celebration, and grief. Renu renders these songs with deep respect and careful attention, treating them as serious literary texts rather than mere folklore.

Figures like Kamla in Maila Aanchal, the LalPanKiBibi of his eponymous story, and the women protagonists of his Sohar stories are drawn with a psychological depth and emotional complexity that was unusual in Hindi fiction of the period. They desire, they suffer, they assert themselves, they fail and endure in ways that challenge both the patriarchal social world they inhabit and the literary conventions that had previously constrained the representation of rural women.

### 9.3 Politics and Development

A recurring theme in Renu's fiction is the betrayal of the rural poor by the postIndependence state. The promises of Independence land reform, poverty eradication, democratic participation are shown being systematically frustrated by a combination of uppercaste inertia, political corruption, bureaucratic indifference, and the structural disadvantages of an economy organised against the interests of the landless poor. The development projects of the 1950s and 1960s irrigation works, flood control, the Green Revolution are depicted not as unambiguous goods but as contested interventions that often serve the interests of the powerful at the expense of the weak.

## 10. Renu's Place in the Aanchalik Sahitya Tradition

### 10.1 Defining Aanchalik Sahitya

'Aanchalik Sahitya' (regional literature) is the critical term most commonly used to classify Renu's work, and it is a term he himself used to describe Maila Aanchal in his author's preface to the novel. But the term requires careful unpacking. It does not simply mean literature that is set in a particular region, or literature that uses regional dialect virtually all literature has some regional basis. Rather, Aanchalik Sahitya in Renu's sense involves a specific literary

stance: one that valorises the regional against the metropolitan, that insists on the integrity and complexity of local cultural worlds, and that refuses to see the village or the small town as a mere backdrop for the drama of urban modernity.

In this sense, Renu's Aanchalik Sahitya has affinities with regional literary traditions in other world literatures: the American regionalism of Willa Cather and William Faulkner, the Russian provincial fiction of Nikolai Leskov and Alexander Ostrovsky, the Latin American magical realism of Gabriel Garcia Marquez (whose Macondo has often been compared to Renu's Merigan gaon). These comparisons illuminate Renu's achievement: he created, in Hindi, a literary geography as vivid and as humanly complex as any in world literature.

### 10.2 Renu's Predecessors and Contemporaries

In the Hindi tradition, Renu's immediate predecessor is Premchand, whose village fiction of the 1920s1930s set the stage for serious engagement with rural life in Hindi prose. But Premchand's village is primarily a stage for ideological conflicts between tradition and modernity, caste oppression and human dignity, feudalism and nascent democracy. Renu's village is more densely textured, more sensorially and culturally specific, more comfortable with moral ambiguity and cultural complexity.

Among Renu's contemporaries, the closest parallel is perhaps Shailendar in Bhojpuri literature, or the writers of the 'GangaJamuni' tradition who sought to represent the cultural hybridity of the North Indian plains. But none of them achieved quite Renu's synthesis of political engagement, cultural celebration, lyrical beauty, and unflinching social critique.

## 11. Critical Reception and Scholarly Debates

### 11.1 Initial Reception

The initial critical reception of Maila Aanchal was, famously, mixed. Some of the Hindi literary establishment accustomed to the urbane, psychologically sophisticated prose of the Nayi Kahani movement found Renu's novel excessively dialectal, plotless, and difficult to categorize. Others recognised it immediately as a landmark. The critic and novelist Jainendra Kumar was among the first to hail it as a masterpiece, comparing it to the great works of

world realist fiction. The Hindi literary world gradually came around, and by the 1960s Renu's canonical status was secure.

### 11.2 Later Scholarly Work

Subsequent decades have seen a rich tradition of scholarly work on Renu's fiction, both in Hindi and in English. Key debates in this scholarship include: the question of how to classify Renu's literary use of Maithili (as dialect writing, as codeswitching, as literary bilingualism, or as something sui generis); the relationship between his fiction and the Maithili language movement; the politics of gender in his representation of village women; and the extent to which his Aanchalik vision constitutes a coherent political programme or merely a cultural romanticism.

### 11.3 Renu and World Literature

In recent decades, there has been growing interest in situating Renu within the context of world literature. His affinities with magical realism (particularly Gabriel Garcia Marquez) have been extensively discussed, though scholars like Francesca Orsini have cautioned against seeing these affinities as mere influencerelations rather than parallel responses to comparable historical situations (colonial/postcolonial societies undergoing rapid modernisation). Renu's work has also been read in relation to postcolonial theory, subaltern studies, and the politics of language in multilingual societies.

## 12. Legacy and Continuing Relevance

### 12.1 Influence on Subsequent Writers

Renu's influence on subsequent Hindi literature has been immense, though often indirect. The generation of Hindi writers who came after him including Shrilal Shukla (Raag Darbari), Vinod Kumar Shukla, and many others have engaged, sometimes critically, with the Aanchalik tradition he founded. The distinctive technique of incorporating folk songs and regional idioms into Hindi prose which Renu pioneered has been widely imitated, though rarely with Renu's mastery. He also had direct influence on Maithili literature, inspiring a generation of Maithili writers to take their own cultural world as serious literary material.

### 12.2 The Mithila Cultural Renaissance

Renu wrote during a period of significant cultural and political ferment in Mithila, and his fiction both reflected and contributed to that ferment. The Maithili language movement, which achieved constitutional recognition in 2003, drew on the cultural prestige that Renu's work had helped to create. The growing international recognition of Madhubani painting, which began in the 1960s, paralleled and intersected with Renu's literary celebration of Mithila. In recent years, the creation of the state of Jharkhand (2000), the growing demands for a separate Mithila state, and the continuing vitality of Maithili literature in print and digital media all speak to the ongoing relevance of the cultural world Renu depicted.

### 12.3 Renu in the Age of Globalization

It might seem that in an age of globalisation, digital culture, and rapid urbanisation, the world Renu depicted the flooded Kosi plains, the Chhath rituals at the water's edge, the songs of absent husbands, the complex negotiations of caste and kinship would have receded into nostalgic irrelevance. In fact, the opposite appears to be the case. The Chhath festival has become perhaps the most widely observed diaspora festival among Bihari and Maithili communities across India and the world. Madhubani painting has achieved global recognition. And Renu's fiction continues to attract new readers who find in it not only a documentary record of a vanished world but a living artistic vision that speaks to the experience of displacement, marginality, and the struggle for dignity.

## 13. Conclusion

This chapter has argued that Phanishwar Nath Renu's engagement with Mithila and Maithili is not a peripheral feature of his work but its very foundation. The cultural world of Mithila its landscape, its folk songs, its ritual calendar, its caste and gender dynamics, its ancient literary heritage in the Maithili language provides Renu with not only his material but his forms, his aesthetics, and his ethics.

Renu demonstrates, through the body of his fiction, that the regional is not the opposite of the universal but its necessary condition. It is only by being fully, uncompromisingly Maithili embedded in the specific sights, sounds, smells,

and struggles of the Kosi plain that his fiction achieves its claim on readers everywhere who have ever felt themselves to be from the margin, to be made of the soiled hem rather than the clean centre.

In the Hindi literary tradition, Renu stands as the writer who most completely made a specific regional culture into a vehicle for the deepest human questions. His Mithila is both a real place and a literary achievement: a world that exists in the imagination of every reader who has passed through his pages, and that continues to expand with each new reading.

> *"Maine apni dharti ko apni bhasha mein likhne ki koshish ki hai. Aur yahi mera sahitya hai. (I have tried to write my land in my language. And this is my literature.)"* **Phanishwar Nath Renu**

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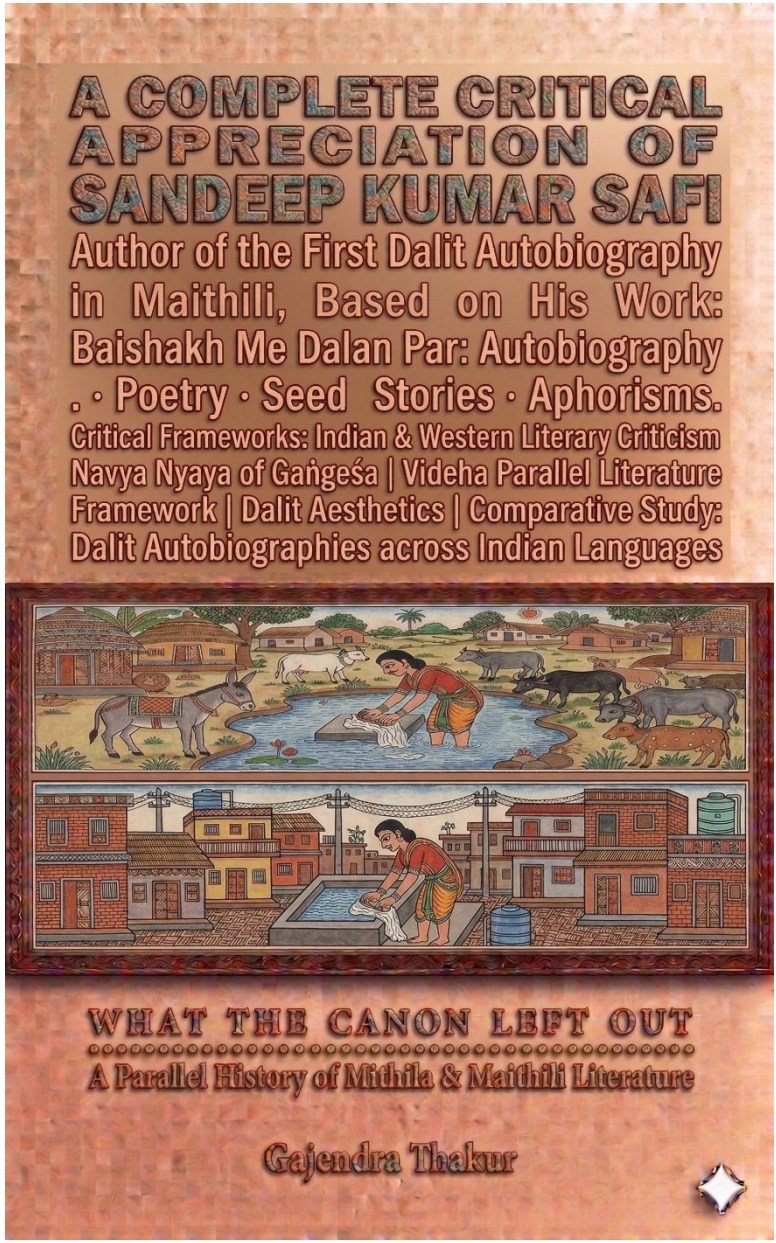
**LESSON 075 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**



# A COMPLETE CRITICAL APPRECIATION OF

# SANDEEP KUMAR SAFI

*Author of the First Dalit Autobiography in Maithili*

Based on His Work:

**(Baishakh Me Dalan Par)**

Autobiography · Poetry · Seed Stories · Aphorisms

Critical Frameworks:

Indian & Western Literary Criticism | Navya Nyaya of Gaṅgeśa

Videha Parallel Literature Framework | Dalit Aesthetics

Comparative Study: Dalit Autobiographies across Indian Languages

## Preface

Sandeep Kumar Safi (उर्फ किरण / alias Kiran), born 7 June 1984 in village Manhath, via Jhanjharpur, District Madhubani, Bihar, is the author of Baishakh Me Dalan Par (In Vaishakh on the Verandah) — a landmark work in Maithili literary history. As Gajendra Thakur, editor of the Videha eJournal, states explicitly in his editorial note at the head of the autobiography section: 'Maithilime Dalit atmakathak sarvathe abhav rahal achhi. Sandeep Kumar Safik atmakatha Mithilak sahitya, samaj aa sanskriti ki hilorait oi abhavak purti karait achhi' — In Maithili there has been a complete absence of Dalit autobiography. Sandeep Kumar Safi's autobiography, while stirring the literature, society and culture of Mithila, fills that absence.

This single editorial declaration establishes the work's historic significance: Baishakh Me Dalan Par (Shruti Prakashan, New Delhi, 2014; 1st edition) is the first Dalit autobiography in the Maithili language. Published in a language with over a thousand years of literary history — from Vidyapati's medieval padas to the parallel literary movement of the twenty-first century —

Safi's text breaks what had been, until 2014, a complete silence: the silence of the dhobi (washerman) community and of Mithila's Dalit communities more broadly within their own literary tradition.

The book is a uniquely structured omnibus: it combines an autobiography (atmakatha khand), a poetry section (kavita khand), a seed-story section (vihani katha khand), a short story section (laghu katha khand), and an aphoristic thought section (vichar bindu khand) in a single binding. This hybrid form is itself a critical statement — it refuses to confine Safi to a single genre, claiming the full spectrum of literary expression for a Dalit voice that mainstream Maithili culture had not previously granted that right.

The present critical appreciation draws on the full text of the work as accessible through the Videha Digital Library (www.videha.co.in/pothi.htm), alongside web research on the Dalit literary tradition across Indian languages and the application of multiple critical frameworks: Gajendra Thakur's Videha Parallel Literature Framework; the Navya Nyaya epistemological tradition of Gangesa Upadhyaya; Indian aesthetic theories of Rasa, Dhvani, and Vakrokti; and Western theories including autobiography theory, Dalit aesthetics (Sharankumar Limbale), postcolonial theory (Spivak), testimonial literature studies, and feminist intersectionality theory.

# Chapter I: The Historical Context — Maithili Literature, Dalit Silence, and the Videha Movement

## 1.1 The Thousand-Year Silence

Maithili literature stretches back to the fourteenth century CE with Jyotirishwar Thakur's Varnaratnakar (the first prose work in any New Indo-Aryan language of eastern India) and to the songs of Pre- Jyotirishwar Vidyapati [ different from Vidyapati (c. 1352-1448)], the poet whose lyrics are so embedded in Maithili cultural identity that they survive in living oral performance to this day. Through this millennium of literary production, the Dalit communities of Mithila — the dhobis, the chamars, the musahars, the doms, the passwans and others who constitute the foundational labour force of Mithila's agrarian and artisan economy — have been almost entirely absent as literary subjects in their own voice.

This absence was systematic rather than accidental. As scholarship on Maithili literature notes, the literary activities of the Maithili-speaking region have historically seen 'the participation of Dalits at not more than one percent.' The Dalit communities have been present in Maithili literature, but in a specific and constrained way: as subjects of upper-caste representation (the poor, the exploited, the folk-character in the social-realist fiction of writers like Lalit or Harimohan Jha) rather than as speaking subjects in their own right. The absence of Dalit autobiography in Maithili before 2014 is the most precise expression of this systematic exclusion: autobiography is the genre that most directly asserts the value and validity of an individual and community's self-knowledge. Its absence in Maithili Dalit writing is the literary equivalent of the social verdict that a Dalit life is not worth narrating.

Maithili folk tradition has always included Dalit creativity: the ballad tradition (lokgatha) of Mithila is largely composed of songs celebrating heroes from the lowest castes (Lorik, Salhes, and others). The Kirtaniya troupes — performing artists from Dalit communities — were the primary vehicles of theatrical culture in medieval Mithila. But formal literary production, publication, and critical recognition — the institutional apparatus of 'Literature' with a capital L — excluded Dalit voices systematically until the emergence of the Videha Parallel Literature Movement.

## 1.2 The Videha Parallel Literature Framework

The Videha eJournal (www.videha.co.in, ISSN 2229-547X, since 2008, edited by Gajendra Thakur) constitutes the institutional context within which Safi's work was produced and published. The Videha movement's explicit project is the recovery of what Thakur calls 'the missing portions, the ignored and non-represented aspects of society' in mainstream Maithili literary production. The movement's motto — 'Manushimih Samskritam' (Humans First in Culture) — signals its commitment to the inclusion of subaltern voices as the primary measure of cultural vitality.

The publication of Safi's Baishakh Me Dalan Par through Shruti Prakashan (the Videha movement's associated publishing house, New Delhi) in 2014 is an institutional act of the highest significance. By producing the first Dalit autobiography in Maithili through the Videha network, the movement both fills a critical gap in the Maithili literary archive and demonstrates that the parallel literature tradition — represented by writers like Rajdeo Mandal (Dhanuk community), Jagdish Prasad Mandal (Yadav community), and Sandeep Kumar Safi (Dhobi/Dalit community) — has now produced the full

range of literary genres across the full social spectrum of Maithili-speaking communities.

### 1.3 Gangesa Upadhyaya and the Epistemology of Dalit Voice

The Navya Nyaya system of Gangesa Upadhyaya — the fourteenth-century Mithila philosopher whose Tattvacintamani systematised the four pramanas (pratyaksha/perception, anumana/inference, upamana/analogy, shabda/verbal testimony) — provides a critical framework of remarkable local relevance. As the Videha critical literature reveals, Gangesa himself came from a socially marginalised family in Mithila, and the Brahminical genealogical apparatus (the Panji) chose to 'completely ignore' his family background. The founder of Mithila's greatest philosophical tradition was a product of caste marginalisation — and yet his epistemological system insists that valid cognition (prama) must be grounded in the actual object of knowledge, not in received tradition or social hierarchy.

Applied to Safi's Baishakh Me Dalan Par: the autobiography constitutes a pratyaksha-pramana (direct perceptual evidence) of the dhobi community's life in contemporary Mithila — a form of knowledge that has never before appeared in the Maithili literary record. It corrects the systematic bhrama (false cognition) produced by a literary tradition that, in excluding Dalit voices, has generated the false universal claim that 'Maithili literature' represents Maithili social reality. The bhrama is that the Brahmin-Kayastha literary tradition represents all of Mithila; the prama offered by Safi's text is the direct perceptual testimony of a life lived outside that tradition's purview.

## Chapter II: The Autobiography — Atmakatha Khand

### 2.1 Structure and Form of the Autobiography

The autobiography section of Baishakh Me Dalan Par is remarkable for its brevity, density, and the range of experience it compresses into its pages. Unlike the full-length Dalit autobiographies of other Indian language traditions (Valmiki's Joothan runs to hundreds of pages; Daya Pawar's Baluta is a substantial multi-chapter work), Safi's autobiography is a condensed document — closer in form to what scholars of autobiography theory call a 'short autobiography' or 'autobiographical sketch' — that nonetheless covers the

essential arc of a Dalit life: family, caste identity, childhood labour, interrupted education, migration, injury, marriage, failed examinations, and the persistence of literary aspiration despite all structural obstacles.

Safi opens his autobiography with a statement about the nature of life itself: 'Jivan ego sangharsha hoait achhi, sangharshamy hoait achhi' — Life is a struggle, it is constituted by struggle. This philosophical opening — placing the autobiography in the framework of universal human struggle before specifying the particular conditions of his own — is a rhetorical strategy of significant sophistication. It universalises before it particularises, refusing the genre convention of Dalit autobiography that begins with the specific wound (the untouchability, the discrimination, the violence) before moving toward universality. Safi reverses this: he begins with the universal condition of struggle and then specifies its particular Dalit inflection.

## 2.2 Identity and Caste Disclosure

The disclosure of caste identity in Safi's autobiography is direct and unapologetic: 'Ham jatik dhobi chhi, harijan (dalit) chhi' — We are of the dhobi caste, we are Harijan (Dalit). This statement — 'I am Dalit, I am a washerman' — is the foundational act of the Dalit autobiographical genre: the assertion of a caste identity that social convention, shame, and the fear of stigma have historically suppressed. The dhobi community in Mithila occupies the position of a service caste whose traditional occupation (washing clothes for landed families) placed them in a relationship of economic dependence and social subordination to the upper castes they served.

Safi's dual name — Sandeep (school identity) and Kiran (village identity) — reflects the dual social world he inhabits. The school is the space of formal identity, official documentation, and aspiration; the village is the space of community, tradition, and caste. This duality of name/identity is not merely a biographical detail but a structural condition of the Dalit subject's social existence: the necessity of navigating between the formal equality promised by education and the constitution, and the actual inequality maintained by caste social structures.

## 2.3 The Geography of Migration

Safi's autobiography traces a geography of migration that is characteristic of subaltern Maithili life in the late twentieth and early twenty-first centuries: from the village of Manhath (Jhanjharpur, Madhubani) to Nepal (1994, age approximately 11, accompanying his didi), then back to the village,

then to Punjab (Chandigarh), then to Bangalore (multiple times). This migrant geography — the movement from Mithila to Nepal, Punjab, and Bangalore in search of livelihood — is the lived reality of millions of Maithili-speaking Dalits and OBCs for whom the village offers insufficient economic opportunity.

The specific detail of Nepal in 1994 — when Safi was approximately ten or eleven years old, working with his elder sister, washing clothes, cooking on wood fires, waking at three in the morning — is the most vivid documentation in the autobiography of child labour. The child Safi works as an adult: 'Bhore tin baje uthi kapra dhoaile. Oi samay hamar umer bujhu je 11-12 ke chhale' — Rising at three in the morning to wash clothes. At that time my age was about 11-12. This is testimony of the most direct kind — the pratyaksha of a child's body doing adult labour — and it stands as the autobiography's most powerful indictment of the conditions that the dhobi community's poverty imposes on its children.

## 2.4 Education as Interrupted Aspiration

The central narrative thread of Safi's autobiography is the pursuit of education against structural obstacles. The pattern is repeated with painful regularity: he begins studying, is forced to stop for economic reasons, migrates, returns, begins again, fails an examination, migrates again. The Board examination failure in Madhubani's Watson School in 2000 ('Ham pariksha pass nai ke paili' — I could not pass the exam) is narrated with characteristic directness — no self-pity, no blame, only the statement of fact and the continuation of effort.

The eventual academic trajectory — Sanskrit Board examination (second division, 2005) from Ketahi-Rampatti School; IA from Shivnandan-Nadkishor Mahavidyalaya, Bhairavasthan (second division); BA from Lalit Narayan Mithila University, Kameshwarnagar Darbhanga (First Class, 2011) — is a narrative of extraordinary persistence. Safi completes his BA First Class while working as a domestic servant in Bangalore, studying whenever time permits, bringing textbooks from the village, sitting the examinations from Bangalore. This trajectory — the daily wage labourer who earns a First Class BA while working in a Bangalore household — is not merely an individual achievement; it is a systemic indictment. The system that produced this situation — in which a First Class degree earner from a Mithila Dalit community cannot find employment — is the subject of Safi's most direct social critique: 'Eteh padhnihar bade afsar hoait achhi muda ham sab kichhu nai

ka pabi rahal chhi' — People said that those who study this much become big officers, but we are not able to do anything.

## 2.5 The Accident and the Body

The most viscerally powerful episode in the autobiography is the accident in Chandigarh: 'Hamra payer me aagi lagi gaile. Hamra pura payer me, payarse edhi se jodh tak jhadaki gaile' — Fire got into my feet. My whole foot, from the heel to the thigh, was scalded. This injury — which incapacitated Safi for three months, required repeated bicycle journeys alone for medical treatment from the distant village of Dhanas — is narrated with remarkable restraint. He does not dramatise the pain; he reports it. The practical consequences occupy more space in the narrative than the physical suffering: all the money earned in Chandigarh spent on medical treatment, the Board examination form filled by friends in his absence, the inability to study, the return home.

This episode illustrates a key characteristic of Safi's autobiographical mode: the Dalit body is not sentimentalised but recorded in its vulnerability. The body that does labouring work — washing clothes, cooking, domestic service — is also the body that is damaged by the conditions of that work, and that damage has concrete economic consequences (all savings consumed by medical costs). The body and the economy are inseparable in Safi's account of his life.

## 2.6 The Closing Credo

Safi closes his autobiography with a statement of cultural pride and literary aspiration that transforms the record of suffering into an affirmation of belonging: 'Ham maithil chhi, Mithile me rahab aur poro saag tori ka gujar karab. Sada chhi sada rahab. Jai Mithila, Jai Mithila Dham, Pranam' — I am Maithil, I will live in Mithila and survive even on poro saag (a humble wild vegetable). I am simple, I will remain simple. Victory to Mithila, Victory to the Land of Mithila, Greetings.

This closing is simultaneously humble and assertive. The reference to poro saag — a wild leafy vegetable that represents the most austere subsistence — claims Mithila as home not through prosperity or achievement but through the willingness to eat what the land provides, however little. The assertion 'Sada chhi sada rahab' (I am simple, I will remain simple) refuses the upward mobility narrative that Dalit autobiography sometimes (under the pressure of the genre convention of 'triumph over adversity') adopts. Safi does not triumph; he

persists. And in his persistence, he claims Mithila and the Maithili language as his own with a territorial and cultural assertion ('Ham maithil chhi') that carries deep resonance within a literary tradition that had implicitly denied him that belonging.

# Chapter III: The Poetry — Kavita Khand

## 3.1 The Formal Character of Safi's Poetry

The poetry section of Baishakh Me Dalan Par contains nineteen poems spanning a remarkable thematic range. Formally, Safi's verse employs the gamaya (village) register of Maithili — the spoken vernacular of the dhobi and related communities — rather than the literary standard Maithili of the Brahmin-Kayastha tradition. This linguistic choice is itself a critical statement about who owns the language: the poetry asserts that gamaya Maithili is a literary language capable of carrying any human experience from the comic to the elegiac, from the social-satirical to the devotional.

The poems are not metrically rigid; they employ a loose rhythmic structure closer to the oral folk tradition (geet, chaita, bidapaiti) of Mithila than to the formal Sanskrit-derived metres of classical Maithili poetry. This formal choice connects Safi's verse to the subaltern oral tradition — the tradition of Dalit and OBC performance poetry that has always been the primary vehicle of lower-caste aesthetic expression in Mithila — while simultaneously claiming for it the dignity of written, published literary form.

## 3.2 The Title Poem: Baishakh Me Dalan Par

The title poem — Baishakh Me Dalan Par (In Vaishakh on the Verandah) — is the collection's central aesthetic statement. Vaishakh (April-May) is the hottest month in the Maithili calendar — the month of blazing sun, dried ponds, dust storms, and the grinding summer work of the agricultural cycle. The dalan (verandah/courtyard) is the social space of Maithili village life — the threshold between the domestic interior and the public street, the space where men gather to talk, play cards, rest in the shade.

The poem captures this summer afternoon with acute sensory specificity: 'Purba hawa seho pet fulaabe / Gham se dekhu ganji bhij gaile / Kaua dadhipar lol babai / Mena jamunpar jhagra karaie / Bagra dalanpar chi-chu-chi-chu / Geet sunaabe' — The eastern wind also bloats the belly / Look, the vest is soaked in sweat / The crow dangles its beak on the branch / The myna

quarrels on the jamun tree / The sparrow on the verandah sings chi-chu-chi-chu. This is Maithili nature poetry of the highest order — exact, sensory, and saturated with the specific natural and acoustic world of Mithila's summer.

The poem is framed by an invitation to play cards ('Aau yau yar, khelaai chhi taas / Bais ke akhan karab ki') that establishes the communal leisure register — the men of the village killing time in the summer heat — while the natural imagery that fills the poem transforms this apparently idle scene into a document of Mithila's specific summer ecology: the crow, the myna, the sparrow; the jamun tree; the buffalo that will be taken to the pond when the heat peaks. This is poetry as ecological and cultural record — the natural world of Mithila seen through the eyes of someone who has spent summers on verandahs doing nothing, because there is nothing to do in the blazing Vaishakh heat.

## 3.3 Roudhi Bha Gaile (The Drought Has Come)

This poem documents the agricultural catastrophe of drought with the specificity of a farmer's observation: 'Sab girhastak khet munh baib gaile / Khetme dekhlai darari phati gaile / Pani bin dhan ohina sukhi gaile' — All the landlords' fields have opened their mouths / In the field I saw cracks splitting apart / Without water the paddy has dried just like that. The image of the field 'opening its mouth' (khet munh baib gaile) is a striking personification — the parched earth as a thirsty creature — that connects the ecological observation to a deeper register of suffering.

The poem moves through the specific agricultural vocabulary of Mithila's drought ecology — dokha (the weevil that enters the parched grain), dakhar (crop damaged by birds), the Jata-Jatin folk performance (a rain-summoning ritual dance performed by the women of lower-caste communities) — and ends with an image of ecological collapse: 'Sanse khete kesaur ka panna bhel' — The entire field turned into the leaf of the kesaur (a water weed that colonises drought-dried fields). The kesaur is a specific ecological signal — it indicates ground that has dried completely, where only weeds can grow. Safi's poem thus functions as both poetry and agricultural observation — a document of climate's effect on the subaltern economy of Mithila.

From the Dhvani (suggestion/resonance) perspective of Anandavardhana, this poem's vyanjana-artha (suggested meaning) extends far beyond the literal description of drought. The drought is simultaneously the ecological drought of a specific season and the permanent drought of the dhobi community's economic life — the land-lessness and material scarcity that is the

structural condition of their existence. The field that 'opens its mouth' is the community's hunger. The Jata-Jatin ritual that 'cannot wake God' is the despair of structural poverty that no ritual propitiation can address.

## 3.4 Bhakjogni (The Firefly)

This poem is one of the most accomplished pieces in the collection — a night-scene rendered with dense sensory imagery: 'Bhukur-bhukur batti badai / Raitak ahiriyame / Hath-hath nai sujhai / Jebaak achhi tolpar / Kukur bhukaaie jhau-jhau-jhau / Sanjh ka bajaaie chhai / Hathme nai achhi lathi-thanga / Narahiya karaaie sor / Maijhla baba gabaaie nirgun / Tamakulpar maraai chot / Bauwa kanaaie bhakjogni le / Badaaie chahun or' — The firefly flickers-flickers and grows / In the darkness of the night / Hand-hand cannot be seen / Going is needed to the neighbourhood / Dogs bark jhau-jhau-jhau / Six o'clock of evening sounds / In hand there is no stick / Narahiya makes noise / Middle-uncle sings nirgun / Strikes the tobacco plant / Child cries wanting the firefly / It grows in all directions.

This is a poem of extraordinary compressed social observation. It captures a specific social moment — the transition from evening to night in a village, the absence of electricity (no lights, only fireflies), the grandchild wanting to catch a firefly, the uncle singing nirgun (mystical devotional songs of the lower-caste Kabir tradition). The social world it depicts — the tobacco-chewing uncle, the darkness, the barking dogs, the child's desire — is the specific world of a lower-caste Mithila household, not the lit, comfortable world of the upper-caste household that has historically been the default setting of Maithili literature.

## 3.5 Social and Gender Poetry

Several poems address the gender dynamics of rural Mithila with a directness that is rare in the mainstream Maithili poetic tradition. Maraike Man Ta Sagme Hardi Nai (Wanting to Beat, But No Turmeric in the Curry) is a devastating portrait of domestic violence and its context: 'Gram ghare dekhla jaaie / Istagon par atyachar badhai / Kam-kaju janani sab bhel' — In the household one sees / Violence against women increases on the stove / All women have become workers. The poem documents the specific labour of rural women — grass and fodder collection, caring for children, cooking — and places this labour in the context of marital violence, using a darkly comic title that subverts the expected domestic scene: the husband wants to beat his wife

but there is no turmeric in the curry, meaning she failed to put it there because she was overworked.

Var Bikaai Lagname (The Groom Is for Sale at the Wedding Season) satirises the dowry system with a folk comedy register: 'Varak ret nai puchu yau babu / Mara mach ka jena dam badhai' — Do not ask the groom's price, master / It rises like the price of a good fish. The comparison of the groom-market to the fish market is precisely the kind of vakrokti (oblique/figurative expression) that Kuntaka's aesthetic theory identifies as the mark of genuine poetic achievement — the unexpected analogy that creates both comic recognition and critical insight simultaneously.

## 3.6 Seasonal and Festive Poetry

Safi's poetry includes beautiful evocations of Maithili seasonal festivals: Jud Shital (the traditional Maithili New Year water festival of Vaishakh), Saraswati Puja (Basant Panchami), Kartik Purnima (the festival of Sama-Chakeva, the brother-sister relationship festival unique to Mithila), and the Maagh winter. These poems situate the Dalit autobiographer not outside Mithila's cultural calendar but fully within it — celebrating the same festivals, experiencing the same seasons, belonging to the same cultural world as the upper-caste communities that have historically arrogated Maithili culture to themselves.

This cultural belonging is politically significant. Dalit autobiography has sometimes been read as a literature of pure protest — a counter-narrative that defines itself entirely through its opposition to the dominant culture. Safi's poetry refuses this reduction: it is simultaneously protest and celebration, critique and love. The Jud Shital poem — 'Omharse aabae / Bade bhaiya / Lotame bharne thandha pani / Mathpar daait jaaie kain' — evokes the specific physical ritual of the festival (the elder brother pouring cold water on the younger's head) with sensory exactness and obvious affective warmth. This is a Dalit poet who loves his culture, including the rituals and festivals of Mithila, and who asserts his equal right to that belonging.

Chapter IV: The Prose — Seed Stories, Short Stories, and Aphorisms

## 4.1 The Vihani Katha (Seed Stories)

The seed story (vihani katha) section contains the two stories Adhiviswas (Half-Belief/Superstition) and Saus-Putahu (Mother-in-Law and Daughter-in-Law). These are compact narrative forms specific to the Videha parallel tradition — extremely short fictions (a few paragraphs) that capture a complete social situation in its essential tensions.

Adhiviswas dramatises a conversation between two women in a village — the 'Orissawali kaniya' (the woman from Orissa) and her companion — in which the companion's superstition and belief in witchcraft (dain tradition) is gently challenged. The narrative operates through the juxtaposition of two epistemic frameworks: the older woman's implicit superstition ('The woman of Sugaunawa had five goddesses enter her body... all the exorcists and healers came') and the educated younger woman's counter-framing ('All this is superstition. In society it is these very things that create quarrels and call each other witch'). The story is told through natural dialogue with specific sensory details (Navratna cooling oil, soap, the smell of a lemon at a door) that anchor the social observation in a specific material world.

Saus-Putahu dramatises the domestic conflict between a mother-in-law and daughter-in-law through a remarkable doubling: both characters are simultaneously attacking each other and claiming the moral high ground. The mother-in-law accuses the daughter-in-law of laziness; the daughter-in-law accuses the mother-in-law of exploitation. The story refuses to resolve this conflict or adjudicate between the two women's claims — instead, it presents both perspectives with equal specificity, creating what Bakhtin would call a 'dialogic' text that cannot be reduced to a single authoritative viewpoint.

## 4.2 The Laghu Katha (Short Stories): Ogarbaah and Pasi Khana

The two short stories — Ogarbaah (The Crop-Watcher) and Pasikha (The Liquor Den) — are the longest and most complex prose pieces in the collection.

Ogarbaah is a meditation on the changing ecology of Maithili agricultural life. The central figure is Nathu Marard, an 'ogarbaah' — a crop-watcher, the person employed by landed farmers to protect their standing crops from birds, animals, and thieves. The story opens with a haunting refrain: 'Bad din bha gaile bhaat khaila. Maruwa roti khaake ab man nai hoaie' — It has been

a long time since eating rice. No longer feels like eating maize bread. This circularity — the story begins and ends with the same longing for rice — frames the entire narrative within the temporal experience of hunger: the hunger that shapes the ogarbaah's relationship to the fields he watches but does not own.

The story moves from the personal (Nathu Marard's specific hunger and labour) to the structural (the changing agricultural economy of Mithila) with a discursive breadth that is unusual for a short story: it analyses the shift from bullock-plough to tractor agriculture, the decline of traditional grain varieties, the depletion of soil fertility through chemical inputs, the loss of communal water infrastructure (ponds, wells), the rise of gas stoves at the expense of wood fires and the organic composting cycle they supported. This agricultural-ecological analysis, embedded within the narrative of a specific crop-watcher's life, is Safi at his most ambitious — using the short story form to carry the analytical weight of a social essay.

The story's central image — the ogarbaah from one field chasing birds into the next field, while the ogarbaah from the next field chases them back — is a brilliant encapsulation of the zero-sum logic of the rural poor's survival: each person protecting their own small territory of welfare by displacing suffering onto their equally poor neighbour. This image operates through what Anandavardhana's Dhvani theory calls dhvani-vyangya — the resonance of a concrete image that suggests a broader social truth.

Pasikha (The Liquor Den) is a social portrait of alcoholism in a village household, narrated primarily through the voice of Bhukhan's wife — a woman who describes, in vivid and increasingly desperate terms, the consequences of her husband's drinking for their family's economic and physical survival. The wife's monologue — delivered to a neighbour woman on the street — is a tour de force of oral social realism: it captures the specific vocabulary, rhythm, and digressive structure of women's conversation in Maithili village society while simultaneously documenting the economics of alcoholism (the radio sold for liquor money, the children unable to pay school fees, the domestic violence), the corruption of the police, and the structural factors that produce alcoholism in marginalised communities (poverty, underemployment, the boredom of the monsoon season).

## 4.3 The Vichar Bindu (Aphoristic Thoughts)

The closing section — Vichar Bindu (Points of Thought) — contains Safi's philosophical reflections in the form of short paragraphs, functioning as a

bridge between the literary and the discursive. The piece Raja Aur Paraja (The King and His Subjects) is the most substantial of these reflections — a meditation on the breakdown of the traditional rural social contract between the landed (raja) and the dependent labour class (paraja). It uses the figure of the mythological king Janaka of Mithila as a counter-example: 'Mithlanchal ka raja chhal raja janak je apan rajyame khetse khalihantak paraja ki kakhno dukhi nai dekh sakai chhal' — The king of the Mithila region was King Janaka who could never bear to see his subjects unhappy from field to granary.

This invocation of Janaka — the mythological ideal of the just Maithili king — in a text about the contemporary breakdown of rural social solidarity is a complex rhetorical move. It affirms a Mithila cultural heritage (the legendary justice of Janaka) while simultaneously contrasting it with the contemporary reality of landlords who have abandoned their traditional obligations to the labouring poor. It is neither a romanticisation of the past nor a straightforward critique of the present — it is a meditation on the gap between cultural ideal and social reality that uses the mythological resource of the Mithila tradition to illuminate a contemporary social problem.

Chapter V: Critical Frameworks Applied

## 5.1 Dalit Aesthetics and the Safi Text

Sharankumar Limbale's foundational theoretical work Towards an Aesthetic of Dalit Literature (Marathi original 1996; English translation by Alok Mukherjee, 2004) provides the most directly applicable theoretical framework for understanding Safi's achievement. Limbale argues that Dalit literature is defined by its 'authenticity of experience' rather than by formal aesthetic criteria derived from the upper-caste literary tradition. The 'highest purpose of Dalit writing,' as the Joothan scholarship articulates it, 'is not beauty of craft, but authenticity of experience.'

Safi's work embodies this principle: its value lies not in the formal complexity of its language (though, as argued above, its gamaya Maithili is both linguistically and aesthetically rich) but in the unprecedented authenticity of its testimony. Baishakh Me Dalan Par is, in Limbale's formulation, a text that 'names' — gives written literary form to — an experience that was previously unnameable within the Maithili literary tradition. The dhobi community's experience of labouring, migrating, studying, failing, persisting, and loving Mithila had no previous literary name in Maithili; Safi's text provides that name.

Limbale also argues that Dalit autobiography functions as 'community autobiography' rather than individual autobiography — that the Dalit autobiographer writes not merely of their individual self but of their community's collective experience. Safi's text confirms this: his individual journey from Manhath to Nepal to Punjab to Bangalore and back is also the journey of thousands of Maithili Dalit migrants who follow the same route driven by the same poverty and the same aspiration.

## 5.2 Autobiography Theory: The Dalit Difference

Western autobiography theory — from Philippe Lejeune's 'autobiographical pact' (the author's commitment to truthful self-representation) to Georges Gusdorf's analysis of autobiography as an expression of Western individualism — has been extensively critiqued by postcolonial and Dalit scholars for its inability to account for the specifically communal and testimonial character of subaltern autobiography.

Dalit autobiography, as scholars have argued, differs from the Western autobiographical tradition in that 'the focus is not on self but Dalit community.' The 'self' in Dalit autobiography is not the sovereign individual of Enlightenment autobiography but a representative subject — a figure whose individual experience is simultaneously the community's experience, whose personal suffering is simultaneously the community's suffering. Safi's autobiography exemplifies this structure: even in its most personal passages (the injury in Chandigarh, the examination failure, the longing for employment), the narrative simultaneously evokes the collective condition of the dhobi community.

The hybrid form of Baishakh Me Dalan Par — autobiography + poetry + seed stories + short stories + aphorisms — also diverges from the Western autobiographical tradition's generic purity. It suggests a conception of literary production that refuses the specialisation of genres, claiming all forms of expression as equally available to the Dalit voice. This generic hybridity is itself a form of literary democratisation.

## 5.3 Testimonial Literature and the Witness Function

Scholars of testimonial literature (following Shoshana Felman and Dori Laub's Testimony: Crises of Witnessing in Literature, Psychoanalysis, and History, 1992) have analysed the specific epistemic and ethical status of texts that bear witness to experiences of systematic violence and oppression. Safi's autobiography functions as testimonial literature in this sense: it bears witness

to the conditions of Dalit life in contemporary Mithila, creating a documentary record that has epistemic authority precisely because it is grounded in lived experience (pratyaksha-pramana).

The testimonial function of Safi's text is reinforced by its compression. Unlike the full-length autobiography that can afford to develop its testimony through extensive narrative, Safi's short autobiography packs its testimony into a dense sequence of episodes — Nepal, the injury, the Board examination failure, Bangalore, the failed recruitment attempts, the First Class BA — each of which stands as a specific, datable, verifiable event in the record of one Dalit man's life. This specificity (dates, places, people) is the testimonial mode's guarantee of authenticity.

## 5.4 Spivak's Subaltern and the Speaking Dhobi

Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's question — 'Can the subaltern speak?' — receives a specific and historically significant answer in Safi's Baishakh Me Dalan Par. The dhobi community of Mithila represents one of the most comprehensively subalterned communities in the region: economically dependent on upper-caste patronage (the traditional system of providing washing services to landed families for grain payments), socially stigmatised (the occupational pollution associated with washing clothes), and culturally invisible in the literary tradition (no Maithili text before 2014 had given a dhobi voice or subjectivity).

Safi's text is, in the most literal sense, the subaltern speaking. He speaks in his own name, in his own gamaya Maithili, about his own community's life, in a published text that enters the Maithili literary archive through the Videha Digital Library and Shruti Prakashan. This speaking does not fully overcome the structural conditions of subalternisation — Safi ends his autobiography still unemployed, still in Bangalore doing domestic service — but it establishes the public existence of a Dalit voice in Maithili literature in a way that cannot be undone.

## 5.5 Navya Nyaya and the Correction of Literary Bhrama

Gangesa Upadhyaya's Navya Nyaya, applied to the literary domain, demands that we ask: what false cognition (bhrama) does this text correct, and what valid cognition (prama) does it establish? The bhrama corrected by Baishakh Me Dalan Par is the systematic false cognition that 'Maithili literature' is exhausted by its Brahmin-Kayastha tradition — that the only life worthy of literary representation in Maithili is the life of the educated, landed, upper-caste

Maithili speaker. This bhrama has been maintained by the institutional apparatus of Maithili literary production (the Sahitya Akademi, the literary journals, the academic criticism) for at least a century.

The prama established by Safi's text is the direct perceptual evidence (pratyaksha) that a dhobi's life in contemporary Mithila — working at three in the morning to wash clothes, migrating to Nepal and Punjab and Bangalore, studying by whatever means possible, loving the Jud Shital festival and the firefly in the dark, worrying about turmeric in the curry and the drought in the fields — is as rich in social complexity, cultural specificity, and human significance as any other life. This prama, established through the four pramanas simultaneously (pratyaksha of lived experience, anumana of structural analysis in the short stories, upamana of comparison with the ideals of King Janaka, and shabda of the community's oral testimony that fills the poetry), constitutes an epistemological revolution in Maithili literary culture.

## 5.6 Bharata's Natyashastra and the Rasas of Dalit Life

Bharata's Natyashastra, with its account of the eight rasas (aesthetic emotional flavours), can be applied to the poetry of Baishakh Me Dalan Par to identify the specific emotional registers that Safi's verse evokes. The dominant rasas are: karuna (compassion/pathos) — evoked by the autobiography's account of the child working at three in the morning, the injury in Chandigarh, the examination failures; vira (heroic resolution) — evoked by the persistence against structural obstacles, the First Class BA earned while working as a domestic servant; adbhuta (wonder) — evoked by the sensory precision of the seasonal poetry, the firefly poem, the Vaishakh verandah poem; and hasya (humour/comedy) — evoked by the satirical poems on the groom-market and the spoiled child.

The specific combination of karuna and hasya — pathos and comedy — is the most distinctive tonal feature of Safi's poetry. Many of his poems hold suffering and humour in the same breath, refusing the binary that would confine Dalit literature to pure protest or pure pain. The poem about the wedding feast (Ek Tham Gelai Bariati) is pure comic observation — the narrator overwhelmed by the sequence of dishes served at the wedding, the rascal (roti, sweets, fish head), ending with 'Hazmolake goti khaelai' (I ate a digestive pill). This is social comedy of a high order — the communal feast as an occasion for gentle self-mockery — and it demonstrates that Safi's literary personality encompasses the full human spectrum.

# Chapter VI: Comparative Study — Safi and Dalit Autobiography across Indian Languages

## 6.1 The Pan-Indian Dalit Autobiographical Tradition

Dalit autobiography in India began in Marathi — with Daya Pawar's Baluta (1978) identified as the first Dalit autobiography in any Indian language — and subsequently developed across multiple languages: Hindi (Omprakash Valmiki's Joothan, 1997; Mohandas Naimishrai's Apne Apne Pinjre, 1995), Tamil (Bama's Karukku, 1992), Kannada (Siddalingaiah's Ooru Keri, 1981), Telugu (G. Kalyan Rao's Untouchable Spring, 2000), Bengali (Manoranjan Byapari's Interrogating My Chandal Life, 2013). Sandeep Kumar Safi's Baishakh Me Dalan Par (2014) adds Maithili to this list, closing what Gajendra Thakur identifies as a 'complete absence' (sarvathe abhav) of Dalit autobiography in the language.

The comparative study of these texts reveals both shared structural features of the Dalit autobiographical genre and significant differences in the specific conditions, tones, and formal strategies of different communities and language traditions. The comparison table below maps these dimensions across five key texts.

**Comparative Matrix: Dalit Autobiographies across Indian Languages**

| Criterion | Sandeep Kumar Safi (Maithili, 2014) | Omprakash Valmiki — Joothan (Hindi, 1997) | Daya Pawar — Baluta (Marathi, 1978) | Bama — Karukku (Tamil, 1992) |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Caste/ Community | Dhobi (Harijan/Dalit, washerman caste) | Chuhra (Valmiki/Bhangi, sweeper caste) | Mahar (Maharashtra's largest Dalit caste) | Paraiyar (Dalit-Christian woman, |

| | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | | | | Tamil Nadu) |
| Language of Text | Maithili (gamaya register) | Hindi (literary-colloquial register) | Marathi (literary register) | Tamil (oral-conversational register) |
| Form | Hybrid: autobiography + poetry + seed stories + aphorisms in single volume | Prose autobiography; vignette-based | Full prose autobiography; detailed narrative | Hybrid: memoir + reflection; fragmented |
| Labour /Caste Work | Washing clothes (dhobi); migrant labourer | Cleaning/ sweeping (bhangi); factory worker | Village labour; Mumbai slum worker | Agricultural labour; domestic worker |
| Geographic Arc | Musaharniyan → Nepal → Punjab → Bangalore → Mithila | Barla village (UP) → Muzaffarnagar → Mumbai → ordnance factory | Village Maharashtra → Mumbai slums | Tamil Nadu village → urban convent |
| Key Themes | Poverty, migration, education denied/persisted, dowry, caste violence, | Untouchability, school discrimination, Brahminical | Balutedar system, rural caste | Gender+caste interse |

| | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | floods, seasonal time of Mithila, joy of Mithili folk life | violence, Ambedkar's influence | economy, city slums, Dalit Panthers | ctionality, religion, faith, Dalit-Christian identity |
| Tone | Resilient, affectionate, folk-lyric, humorous in places, not aggressively confrontational | Simmering outrage, analytical, assertive | Unflinching, raw, structurally complex | Anguished, spiritual, feminist |
| Navya Nyaya Application | Pratyaksha of dhobi life; corrects brahmic bhrama of Maithili literature | Pratyaksha of chuhra experience; anumana of systemic caste logic | Sabda of Mahar community memory; inference of structural violence | Vyanjana (suggestion) of gendered caste suffering |
| Ambedkar's Role | Implicit: assertion of dignity, education, constitution; no explicit Ambedkar reference | Explicit: Ambedkar transforms Valmiki into 'speaking subject' | Explicit: Dalit Panthers, Ambedkarite movement context | Implicit: constitutional promise vs lived reality |

## 6.2 Safi and Valmiki: The Dhobi and the Chuhra

The most immediate and instructive comparison is between Safi's Baishakh Me Dalan Par and Omprakash Valmiki's Joothan — both accounts of North Indian Dalit communities (dhobi and chuhra respectively) within communities historically associated with laundry and cleaning labour, writing in major north Indian languages (Maithili and Hindi) from the late twentieth/early twenty-first century context.

The most striking difference is formal: Valmiki's Joothan is a full-length autobiographical narrative, structured chronologically and developed with extensive psychological and social detail. Safi's autobiography is compressed and fragmentary — more a sequence of testimony-capsules than a developed narrative. This formal difference reflects different literary contexts: Valmiki writes within an established Hindi Dalit literary tradition that had been developing since the 1980s and had already produced multiple autobiographies; Safi writes in a tradition that had no previous Dalit autobiography, and the compressed form may reflect both the constraints of a first work and a deliberate choice to pack maximum testimony into the available space.

The tonal difference is equally significant. Valmiki's Joothan 'brims with a quiet sense of outrage'; the simmering anger of a man who has experienced systematic dehumanisation and who has found his voice through the mediation of Ambedkar's movement. Safi's autobiography is more affectionate and less outraged — it documents suffering but does not dwell in anger; it records injustice but moves quickly to the next episode; it ends with a declaration of love for Mithila rather than a call for transformation. This tonal difference may reflect the different conditions of production: Valmiki writes after decades of politicisation within the Hindi Dalit literary movement; Safi writes at the beginning of what may become a Maithili Dalit literary tradition, and his tone is that of a pioneer claiming a space rather than a militant challenging an established system.

## 6.3 Safi and Daya Pawar: The Baluta System and the Dhobi System

Daya Pawar's Baluta is named after the baluta system — the traditional arrangement in Maharashtra's villages by which lower-caste service communities (mahars, chamars, and others) received fixed annual payments in grain from the village's landed communities in exchange for specific service

obligations. The baluta system is Maharashtra's version of the jajmani system — the formal institutionalisation of caste-based labour exploitation as a quasi-contractual arrangement.

The dhobi community of Mithila operated within an analogous system: Safi's autobiography describes how his parents washed clothes for landed families and received grain in payment — 'Pahile ek mota kapra dhoai chhal hamar maa-babu ta girhast sab panch ser dhan nai ta du kilo aata dait chhalai' — Earlier when washing one bundle of clothes, the landowner would give five seers of paddy or two kilos of flour. The exploitation documented in Baluta and the exploitation documented in Baishakh Me Dalan Par are structurally analogous — both are versions of the jajmani/baluta system of caste-bound service labour — but expressed in dramatically different narrative registers. Pawar's Baluta is a detailed social and psychological document; Safi's account is compressed, almost matter-of-fact, treating the grain-payment for washing as simply 'the way things were.'

## 6.4 Safi and Bama: Gender, Form, and the Dalit-Mithila Woman

Bama's Karukku — written from within the Paraiyar Dalit-Christian community of Tamil Nadu — is the most formally experimental of the major Indian Dalit autobiographies. Bama's text combines memoir, social analysis, and spiritual reflection in a fragmented, non-linear form that has been compared to the Tamil folk oral tradition. The title — Karukku — means both the sharp edges of palmyra leaves and the traditional form of a children's song: a word that carries both danger and lyric beauty simultaneously.

Safi's hybrid form — autobiography + poetry + stories + aphorisms — bears a structural resemblance to Bama's fragmented multiplex form, suggesting that the single-genre autobiography may be less adequate to the complexity of Dalit experience than hybrid forms that combine testimony, lyric, narrative, and reflection. Both writers seem to sense that no single literary mode can contain the fullness of what they need to say; both create containers that are larger and more various than the conventional autobiography.

The gender difference is significant: Bama's Karukku is written by a Dalit woman and carries the double burden of caste and gender oppression. Safi's text is written by a Dalit man who is largely sympathetic to the conditions of the women around him (the poems on domestic violence and the dowry system; the stories that give women complex voices) but does not write from within female experience. The Maithili Dalit literary tradition awaits its first Dalit woman autobiographer — a voice that will bring to the Maithili literary

record the specifically gendered experience of the dhobi or other Dalit women of Mithila.

### 6.5 The Question of Ambedkar

One notable feature of Safi's text, compared to the canonical Dalit autobiographies of other languages, is the absence of explicit reference to B.R. Ambedkar. In Valmiki's Joothan, Ambedkar's text functions as the transformative encounter that makes Valmiki into a 'speaking subject' — the discovery of Ambedkar's writing is the turning point of the autobiography. In Bama's Karukku, the Dalit-Christian tradition provides the institutional framework of resistance. In Pawar's Baluta, the Dalit Panthers and their Ambedkarite politics constitute the political horizon of the narrative.

Safi's text operates without this explicit Ambedkarite framework. The rights he claims (the constitutional right to education, the right to marry across caste lines in Panchaiti, the dignity of the dhobi community's labour) are implicitly Ambedkarite — they draw on the constitutional legacy of Ambedkar's work — but Ambedkar is not named, his writings are not cited, the Dalit political movement is not explicitly invoked. This absence may reflect the specific conditions of Maithili Dalit literary production, which lacks the institutional apparatus (Dalit literary organisations, journals, movements) that in Maharashtra, Hindi, and Tamil provided writers with a politicised intellectual framework for their autobiographical self-assertion.

## Chapter VII: Safi's Place in Literary History — Synthesis and Conclusions

### 7.1 The Historic Significance of the First

The fact of being first carries enormous literary-historical weight. Daya Pawar's Baluta is remembered not only for its literary achievement but for the historical fact of being the first Dalit autobiography in Marathi (and in any Indian language); Valmiki's Joothan occupies a similar foundational position in Hindi Dalit literature. Safi's Baishakh Me Dalan Par holds this foundational position in Maithili: it is the first, and its existence changes the Maithili literary landscape permanently.

After Baishakh Me Dalan Par, it is no longer possible to claim — consciously or unconsciously — that Maithili literature is complete without Dalit voices. The text has established a literary precedent: future Maithili Dalit writers will be able to situate themselves within a tradition that Safi began. The absence that Gajendra Thakur identified — 'Maithilime Dalit atmakathak sarvathe abhav' — has been filled.

## 7.2 The Dhrupad of the Dhobi Community

The classical Maithili tradition from Vidyapati onwards includes the dhrupad (devotional lyric) — a song form characterised by its deep, stable, unhurried exploration of spiritual experience. Safi's poetry, with its affectionate observation of Mithila's seasonal world, its folk imagery, and its communal emotional register, is — paradoxically — close in spirit to this classical tradition, even as it is radically different in social position.

Where Vidyapati sang the longing of Radha for Krishna in the metaphors of Mithila's natural world — the lotus pond, the kadamba tree, the monsoon rain — Safi sings the longing of the dhobi community for dignity, education, and security in the metaphors of the same natural world — the firefly, the jamun tree, the parched field, the vaishakh verandah. The metaphorical material is the same; the social position is the opposite. This is the deepest literary irony of Safi's achievement: he writes in and through the imagery of the classical Maithili tradition, but from outside its social privilege, giving voice to the community that has always been present in Mithila's natural world but never before in its literature.

## 7.3 Future Directions for Maithili Dalit Literature

Baishakh Me Dalan Par points toward several future possibilities for Maithili Dalit literary production. The compressed form of Safi's autobiography suggests the possibility of a full-length Maithili Dalit autobiography — a work that develops with the narrative scope of Joothan or Baluta the social complexity that Safi's text can only gesture toward in its brevity. The social criticism embedded in the short stories — particularly Ogarbaah's agricultural-ecological analysis — suggests the possibility of a Maithili Dalit novel of rural life, in the tradition of Rajdeo Mandal's Hamar Tol but from within the Dalit community's specifically.

The most urgent gap identified by Safi's text is the absence of Maithili Dalit women's writing. The women who appear in his poetry and prose — the wife in Pasikha who works while her husband drinks, the woman threatened by

the panchayat in the seed stories, the daughter whose marriage occasions the dowry reflection in the autobiography — are complex and fully realised presences; but they are seen through a male gaze. The Maithili Dalit literary tradition will achieve its full potential when it includes the direct testimony of Dalit women from within their own experience.

## 7.4 Final Assessment

Sandeep Kumar Safi's Baishakh Me Dalan Par is a work of enduring literary and historical significance. Its literary achievement lies in the gamaya Maithili of its poetry — which at its best (Bhakjogni, Baishakh Me Dalan Par, Roudhi Bha Gaile) achieves a precision and resonance that places it among the most distinctive verse of contemporary Maithili literature — and in the social realism of its short stories, which use the conventions of the Videha parallel tradition's compressed narrative form to carry sustained social analysis. Its historical achievement lies in the simple, world-changing fact of its existence: the first written testimony of Dalit life in the Maithili language.

Applied through the Navya Nyaya framework: Safi's text achieves the prama (valid cognition) of the dhobi community's life through the pratyaksha of first-hand experience; corrects the bhrama of mainstream Maithili culture's exclusionary literary representation; and provides through the shabda of published literary testimony an authoritative record of a social world that had previously been unable to speak in its own name within Maithili literature's institutional structures. In Gangesa's terms, it moves the Maithili literary cognition of Dalit life from bhrama to prama — from false cognition to valid knowledge.

The book's epigraph — a dedication to Safi's parents (Sitaram Safi and Sita Devi) and to playwright Anand Kumar Jha — places it within both family and literary community. The dedication to Anand Kumar Jha signals Safi's awareness of and connection to the Videha literary movement's theatrical dimension (Anand Kumar Jha is a playwright in the Bechan Thakur tradition). The book is thus from its first page situated within a community of relationships — family, literary, communal — that gives the individual voice its social weight and meaning.

'Jai Mithila, Jai Mithila Dham, Pranam' — Victory to Mithila, Victory to the Land of Mithila, Greetings. These are Safi's final words. They are the words of a man who has been refused, repeatedly, by the social structures of Mithila — refused employment, refused education, refused the dignity of a secure livelihood. And yet he ends with a greeting to the land that has refused

him. This is not masochism; it is an assertion of belonging that no economic or social system can revoke. Sandeep Kumar Safi belongs to Mithila. His text has proven it, for all of literary history.

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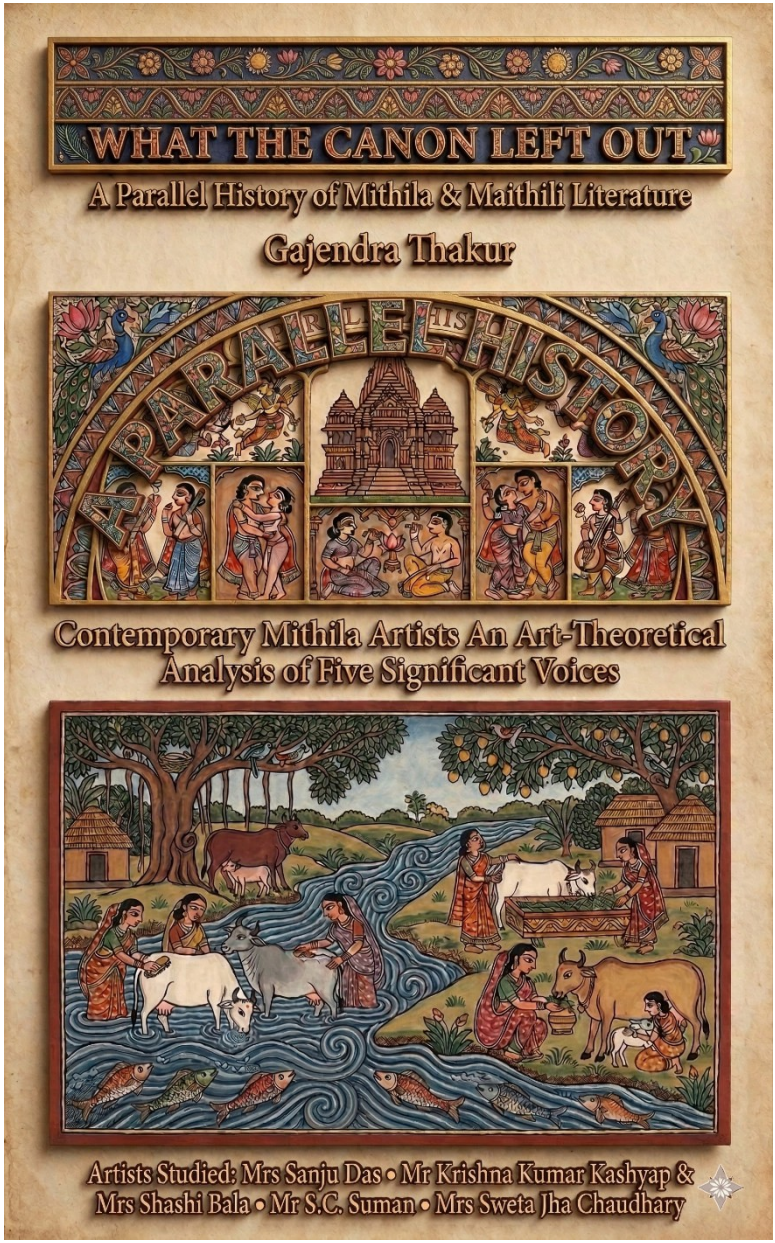

# Contemporary Mithila Artists

*An Art-Theoretical Analysis of Five Significant Voices*

**Artists Studied:**

**Mrs Sanju Das • Mr Krishna Kumar Kashyap & Mrs Shashi Bala**

**Mr S.C. Suman • Mrs Sweta Jha Chaudhary**

## I. Introduction: The Mithila Art Tradition and Its Contemporary Negotiation

This critical study examines the artistic practices, theoretical positions, and cultural significance of five contemporary Mithila artists: Mrs Sanju Das, Mr Krishna Kumar Kashyap (alongside Mrs Shashi Bala, his artistic collaborator), Mr S.C. Suman, and Mrs Sweta Jha Chaudhary. All five figures appear prominently in the special art issue of Videha (Issue 368, April 2023), a leading Maithili e-journal edited by Gajendra Thakur, which dedicated an entire section to debating the development of Mithila painting in its contemporary and modernising forms.

The study applies several key art-theoretical frameworks to analyse these artists, including: Feminist Art Theory, the Folk/Fine Art Continuum Debate, Postcolonial Aesthetics, Formalist and Iconographic Analysis, and the Political Economy of Art. The tension between tradition and modernity, between sacred iconography and secularised contemporary expression, between erotic-spiritual inheritance (as in the Kamasutra-Kohbar tradition) and contemporary censure, runs through all five profiles.

### The Mithila Art Tradition: A Brief Theoretical Background

Mithila painting (also called Madhubani art) has its roots in ritual wall-painting in the Mithila region of northern Bihar and southern Nepal. For centuries, it was practised almost exclusively by women on the mud-plastered walls of domestic interiors, particularly the kohbar-ghar (nuptial chamber). As art historian Yves Vequaud documented in The Women Painters of Mithila (1977), this was not mere decoration but a spiritually charged, cosmological and fertility-symbolic

practice, embedding Tantric and Shakta imagery, divine narratives, and erotic symbolism within the marital space.

The art form's major transformation to paper and canvas occurred in the 1960s, when the All-India Handicrafts Board, responding to famine conditions in Bihar, commercialised these paintings. This shift, theorised by David Szanton as the transition from 'folk art to art,' has produced what we now understand as contemporary Mithila painting: a hybrid practice negotiating ritual origin, market demand, personal expression, feminist assertion, and national and international reception.

The artists under study here represent distinct nodes within this contemporary negotiation. Together, they embody the central tensions of any living folk-to-contemporary art transition: authenticity versus innovation, tradition versus transgression, regional identity versus global legibility.

## II. Mrs Sanju Das: The Self-Taught Modernist and the Question of Obscenity

### Biographical and Contextual Overview

Sanju Das was born in Kamrauli village, Darbhanga district, Bihar. She is a graduate and a self-taught painter who began her career in traditional Mithila painting, inspired by her mother Devaki Devi, and transitioned after marriage to the contemporary artist Ravindra Kumar Das to the register of modern and contemporary art. She is the first artist from the Mithila painting tradition to enter modern art practice, and her work is collected by the National Gallery of Modern Art (NGMA), New Delhi. She has held six solo exhibitions across India and participated in numerous group shows. Her work has received the Bihar Government's 'Kumud Sharma Award' and has been displayed at Bihar Museum, Patna.

According to multiple critics published in Videha Issue 368, Das's paintings combine folk memory, rural feminist subjectivity, and a formal vocabulary drawn from both Mithila tradition and modern art. Her compositions merge the decorative flatness of Madhubani with the psychological interiority more typical of post-Impressionist and postcolonial feminist painting. Critics note similarities in her approach to colour to Paul Gauguin and Marc Chagall, though her content is rooted in the experiential reality of Mithila's women.

## Primary Theoretical Framework: Feminist Art Theory

Sanju Das is most productively understood through the lens of Feminist Art Theory, particularly as theorised by Linda Nochlin (Why Have There Been No Great Women Artists?, 1971), Griselda Pollock (Vision and Difference, 1988), and, in the Indian context, by the MAP Academy's studies of the feminist history of Indian art.

### ⬛ The Male Gaze and Its Subversion

A central controversy surrounding Das is the charge of 'obscenity' levelled at some of her paintings (notably the Goa beach scene, published in Outlook magazine). In her own essay in Videha Issue 368, Das explicitly challenges this discourse: she argues that obscenity resides not in artworks but in the gaze of the viewer. Her argument aligns with feminist art theory's critique of the objectifying male gaze identified by John Berger (Ways of Seeing, 1972) and Laura Mulvey (Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema, 1975). Das observes that the same body that is considered obscene in one social context is worshipped in another. She draws on classical precedents—Geet Govind, Vidyapati's poetry, Khajuraho, tantric Shiva-Shakti imagery, the kohbar—to argue that the erotic in Indian artistic tradition is inseparable from the sacred.

> *"Obscenity does not reside in nature or the artwork; it resides in the perspective of the individual. If your perspective is pure, everything in the world is pure." — Sanju Das (Videha 368)*

### ⬛ Representation of Women's Labour and Interiority

Das's paintings consciously depict women's labour, desire, aspiration, and agency. Unlike the predominantly ritual-decorative function of traditional Mithila painting, her work renders interiority. In her celebrated 'Midnight Talk' series, the psychological dimension of female experience is the primary subject. Mukesh Dutt, writing in Videha 368, notes that even in her rural genre scenes, there is "a current of feminism," visible in the way women are agents of their daily world, not mere decorative figures. This constitutes what Pollock calls a 'positioning' strategy: using the conventional language of folk art but directing its formal energy toward representing women's subjectivity rather than divine narratives or fertility symbols.

### ⬛ Self-Taught Practice and the Critique of Institutional Art Education

Das is a self-taught painter who was denied admission to art college. Yet her work was acquired by the NGMA and praised by leading art critics and artists. As she notes, "Today the students and teachers of the art college that did not

admit me also respect me as an artist." This reversal is theoretically significant: it challenges the gatekeeping function of institutional art education and aligns with what Paul Willis (Common Culture, 1990) theorises as the creative agency embedded in everyday and non-institutional cultural practice.

### Secondary Framework: The Folk/Fine Art Continuum

Das straddles the boundary between Mithila folk tradition and contemporary fine art. In interviews documented in Videha 368, she articulates this consciously: "The difference between modern art and folk art is not as large as people think; it's mainly a difference of medium." Her practice corroborates Jyotindra Jain's analysis (in the context of Ganga Devi) that the best contemporary Mithila artists do not abandon tradition but transform it through individual vision. Her use of folk motifs, decorative borders, and flattened forms within compositionally complex and psychologically loaded paintings is a formal embodiment of this dialectic.

### Critical Assessment

Das represents one of the most theoretically rich figures in contemporary Indian folk-to-modern art. Her critical significance lies in three areas: (1) her challenge to the discourse of obscenity, which has broader implications for debates about artistic freedom and censorship in India; (2) her expansion of the Mithila repertoire to include women's interiority and desire; (3) her demonstration that self-taught practice from a folk tradition can produce work of national and international significance. The controversy surrounding her work is itself evidence of the political stakes of feminist art: as Griselda Pollock observed, feminist art does not just add women's perspectives but restructures the entire grammar of representation.

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## III. Mr Krishna Kumar Kashyap & Mrs Shashi Bala: The Radical Folk Universalist and the Collaborative Painter

### Biographical and Contextual Overview

Krishna Kumar Kashyap (born 1949, Bihar) was expelled from school at age 14 for failure to pay fees. This experience of institutional exclusion shaped his

lifelong commitment to making education and art accessible to marginalised, illiterate, and lower-caste women in Bihar. Kashyap developed a unique pedagogy that taught literacy through the geometric forms of Mithila art and traditional tattoo (godna) body painting. He wrote ten books on Mithila art—unprecedented in the literature of this form—and translated the Geet Govind into Maithili. He established folk art teaching centres in villages throughout Mithila, connecting hundreds of women to economic livelihoods through painting. He is described in Videha 368 as a "social reformer, a cultural ambassador for women's uplift."

Crucially, the editor of Videha, Gajendra Thakur, notes that Kashyap worked inseparably with Shashi Bala, and has editorially added "(and Shashi Bala)" wherever Kashyap's name appears in the special issue, stating that "there is no surviving painting by Kashyap that was not made jointly by Kashyap and Shashi Bala." This makes them a collaborative artistic unit of extraordinary historical interest in the context of Mithila art, which has been almost entirely attributed to individual women.

Some of Kashyap's paintings were based on Geet Govind's verse and incorporated imagery of the erotic-devotional tradition, which brought him controversy. As fellow artist Sanju Das has noted, these paintings were never made public by Kashyap himself, precisely because of the risk of miscomprehension in an environment hostile to explicit sacred-erotic imagery.

## Primary Theoretical Framework: Postcolonial Pedagogy and Folk Art as Epistemology

Kashyap's work is most fruitfully read through the theoretical traditions of Paulo Freire (Pedagogy of the Oppressed, 1968) and the Indian postcolonial theorisation of subaltern knowledge by scholars such as Ashis Nandy. Kashyap's central insight—that the geometric vocabulary of Mithila painting can function as an alphabet, a portal to literacy for those the formal education system has excluded—is a direct application of Freirean critical pedagogy: the belief that oppressed communities possess their own knowledge systems that can be the basis of emancipation.

> *"His main message to illiterate women was: how to earn by learning, and become emancipated by work and education." — Kashyap Art School*

### ⬛ Art as Social Capital

Kashyap's work fundamentally challenges the Western bourgeois separation of 'high art' from utilitarian craft. By insisting that Mithila painting be understood

not as decorative handicraft but as a medium of economic empowerment and social transformation, Kashyap anticipates Pierre Bourdieu's analysis of cultural capital (The Rules of Art, 1992): art is not merely aesthetic; it is a form of social power. For marginalised women in Mithila, access to the art form was access to markets, income, dignity, and, through Kashyap's pedagogy, literacy itself.

## Shashi Bala: The Invisible Collaborator

The editorial decision by Gajendra Thakur to restore Shashi Bala's name to the record is an act of art-historical feminist correction. The invisibility of Shashi Bala within the received narrative of Kashyap's work is a microcosm of the wider invisibility of women's labour in art history. This dynamic has been extensively theorised by Rozsika Parker and Griselda Pollock (Old Mistresses: Women, Art and Ideology, 1981), who argue that the very category of 'craft' versus 'fine art' has been gendered: women's artistic labour is consistently categorised as craft, amateur, or auxiliary, while men are elevated to the status of 'artist.'

Shashi Bala was from Sarisav-Pahi village, had a certificate course in Mithila painting, and participated in exhibitions at XLRI Jamshedpur, Gram-Shree Mela, and Kala Mandir. Her recovery in the Videha essay, not just as a biographic footnote but as an equal co-creator, is a model for how the art histories of Mithila must be rewritten.

## Secondary Framework: The Kama-Shastra Tradition and Sacred Eroticism

A key element of Kashyap's work was his engagement with the Geet Govind and Kamasutra traditions as legitimate sources for visual art. This positions his work within the larger Indic theoretical understanding of kama (erotic love) as one of the four purusharthas (goals of life). Critic Govind Chandra Das, writing in Videha 368, argues compellingly that "no pictorial style exists without the Kamasutra" and that the kohbar's secret erotic imagery (the koni-khonchi, or hidden corners) has always been present within Mithila painting. Kashyap's sin, in the eyes of conservative critics, was making this tradition visible, legible, and non-ritual—presenting it to the general public without the protective frame of the marriage ceremony.

This controversy maps directly onto debates in Indian aesthetic theory between the Brahmanical concept of rasa (emotional/aesthetic essence) and social

propriety (loka-dharma). The nine rasas include shringara (erotic love) as the foremost; the theoretical tradition of Sanskrit aesthetics from Bharata's Natyashastra to Abhinavagupta's Abhinavabharati has consistently legitimated the erotic as a primary aesthetic category. Kashyap and Shashi Bala's work thus stands within a theoretically respectable tradition, even if it sits uncomfortably with contemporary social conservatism.

### Critical Assessment

Kashyap and Shashi Bala represent one of the most theoretically complex cases in contemporary Mithila art. As a pedagogue, Kashyap is unequivocally significant: his contribution to women's literacy and economic empowerment through art is a model of what the anthropologist Arjun Appadurai calls the "capacity to aspire." As an artist, his work on the kama-shastra tradition is both theoretically grounded and socially courageous. The joint attribution of their work by the Videha editor is both a scholarly correction and an ethical statement. The major critical gap in the field remains the absence of a systematic catalogue of Kashyap and Shashi Bala's surviving work, which urgently needs to be compiled and assessed.

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## IV. Mr S.C. Suman: Tradition and Modernity in Dialogue

### Biographical and Contextual Overview

S.C. Suman is a Mithila painter based in Nepal, where he has held numerous exhibitions at the Siddhartha Art Gallery in Kathmandu's Babarmahal, including his eleventh solo exhibition highlighted in Videha 368. He is described as a well-known name in the Mithila art field, whose paintings have earned considerable praise. He learned painting from his mother, in the traditional mode of intergenerational transmission that has sustained Mithila art for centuries. His paintings range in price from 17,000 to 80,000 rupees and sell readily, reflecting both market confidence and critical recognition.

Suman is particularly notable for bridging the traditional and the contemporary within the Mithila form itself, without the radical rupture undertaken by Sanju Das. His work is described by the literary figure Dhirendra Premrishi (in Videha 368's Nepal section) as advancing Mithila painting while "keeping both feet on the ground"—that is, remaining rooted in the formal and thematic

traditions of Mithila while engaging the visual and conceptual vocabulary of modernity.

## Primary Theoretical Framework: Formalism and the Mithila Aesthetic

Suman's work invites analysis through the lens of formalist aesthetics—particularly Roger Fry's concept of 'significant form' and Clive Bell's aesthetics of form over content. Mithila painting is inherently formalist in its orientation: the tradition valorises geometric precision, linear articulation, the avoidance of blank space (the horror vacui principle), and vibrant colour relation above narrative or psychological depth. Suman works within this aesthetic system while gently modernising it.

The key formal principle of traditional Mithila painting—that every inch of surface should be filled, that the composition should be a balanced totality—aligns interestingly with the Islamic arabesque tradition and with the Symbolist painter's total surface. In Suman's hands, this principle is retained but the subject matter broadens from ritual to include the contemporary Mithila life-world, giving his paintings both formal coherence and social documentation value.

## Secondary Framework: Art and Market, Commodification Debate

Suman's frank engagement with the commercial market raises important theoretical questions about commodification in folk art. In his interview cited in Videha 368, he acknowledges the market realities of Mithila painting bluntly, noting the international demand and the premium prices his works command. This connects to the wider debate in cultural economics between the view that commercialisation degrades folk art (the authenticity argument, common among cultural nationalists) and the view that market access is enabling (the empowerment argument, supported by economists of culture such as Tyler Cowen in In Praise of Commercial Culture, 1998).

Suman's position is implicitly pragmatic: the market has sustained Mithila painting in Nepal as a viable livelihood, and his success within that market reflects the quality and distinctiveness of his vision. The critical question raised by Dhirendra Premrishi—whether the state is doing enough to support Mithila painting—is a structural one that transcends individual artists: it is about the political economy of cultural labour.

### Critical Assessment

Suman occupies a distinct and underappreciated position in the Mithila art field: the master of synthesis, the artist who keeps the formal tradition alive while expanding its visual vocabulary. His critical significance is different from Das's radicalism or Kashyap's pedagogical mission; he represents the essential continuity without which any tradition dies. His Nepal-based practice also highlights the cross-border nature of Mithila culture, reminding us that this art form belongs to a civilisational region that the political boundary between India and Nepal cuts across. A deeper critical literature on Suman's formal innovations within the Mithila aesthetic system remains to be written.

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## V. Mrs Sweta Jha Chaudhary: The Trained Artist and the Everyday Sacred

### Biographical and Contextual Overview

Sweta Jha Chaudhary is from Sarisav-Pahi village, Madhubani, and holds a Bachelor's degree in Fine Arts and Home Science, along with a Certificate Course in Mithila Painting. She has exhibited at XLRI Jamshedpur's cultural programme, Gram-Shree Mela Jamshedpur, and Kala Mandir Jamshedpur (both exhibition and workshop). She has served as a judge in art competitions at NIT Jamshedpur, was an art teacher for Mithila painting at Basera, Jamshedpur (2002-07), and has created wall paintings for Women's College Library and Hotel Boulevard, Jamshedpur. Her work has been sponsored by corporate bodies including TISCO and AISADA, and she has private collectors for her paintings.

Chaudhary's work, as presented in Videha 368 through a portfolio of paintings with editorial descriptions, centres on the quotidian rituals and affective relationships of Mithila life: the harvest, the swing in the monsoon rains, the bridal palanquin, the childhood game of kariya-jhummari. Her painting of the Radha-Krishna leitmotif is described as an attempt to visualise the universal feeling of love through the classical devotional template.

## Primary Theoretical Framework: Iconography and the Sacred Everyday

Chaudhary's work is best approached through the iconographic method developed by Erwin Panofsky (Meaning in the Visual Arts, 1955), which distinguishes between: (1) the pre-iconographic level of natural subject matter (what is literally depicted); (2) the iconographic level of conventional symbolic meaning (the established religious or mythological significance of images); and (3) the iconological level of intrinsic meaning (what the image reveals about the culture and world-view that produced it).

At the iconographic level, Chaudhary's paintings draw on the standard Mithila repertoire: Radha-Krishna for erotic-devotional love, the sawan swing for seasonal joy, the doli (palanquin) for the liminal transition of marriage. These are not merely decorative choices; they are coded cultural statements. The doli painting, for instance, depicts the new bride's inner conflict ("the sorrow of leaving the natal home and the joy of a new life") through a composition in which the bearers are oblivious to the emotional complexity they carry—a subtle formal embodiment of the social invisibility of women's inner experience.

### ⬛ The Everyday Sacred

Chaudhary's significance lies in her focus on the sacred within the everyday—what Rudolf Otto called the 'numinous' embedded in ordinary domestic experience. Her painting of the paddy harvest, which shows women processing grain while men bring it from the field, is simultaneously a documentation of gendered labour division, a celebration of communal rural life, and a ritual-symbolic act (grain and harvest being central to Mithila ceremonial painting tradition).

## Secondary Framework: Folk Art as Cultural Memory and Social Document

Chaudhary has formal training that sets her apart from many Mithila painters; she is one of the few with both academic art education and a grounding in the folk tradition. This dual formation positions her work as a bridge between the two epistemologies of art-making: the formal (compositional, technical, theoretically self-conscious) and the traditional (experiential, embodied, communal).

The art historian Partha Mitter (The Triumph of Modernism: India's Artists and the Avant-Garde, 2007) has argued that the dichotomy between 'folk' and

'modern' in Indian art was partly a colonial construction, one that undervalued the sophisticated visual intelligence of folk practitioners. Chaudhary's dual formation is a live refutation of this dichotomy: her paintings show that formal training and folk tradition are enriching, not mutually exclusive.

### Critical Assessment

Chaudhary represents the important category of the formally trained folk artist who returns to and enriches the tradition. Her work is less radical or provocative than Das's, less pedagogically ambitious than Kashyap's, less synthetically innovative than Suman's—but it is accomplished, iconographically rich, and culturally invaluable as a documentation of Mithila women's life-world in the early twenty-first century. The major critical question her work raises is about the relationship between corporately and institutionally sponsored art and artistic autonomy: her sponsorship by TISCO, banks, and hotels suggests a market integration that may over time steer subject matter toward the palatably decorative and away from the socially complex.

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## VI. Comparative Analysis: Five Practices, Five Positions

### The Gender of Mithila Painting

All five artists, in different ways, are engaged with the gendered politics of Mithila painting. Das and Chaudhary, as women artists, work within a tradition historically defined as women's practice but now contested and opened to male participation (Kashyap, Suman). The recovery of Shashi Bala's collaborative role, and the very existence of male artists like Kashyap and Suman within the field, raises the question of whether the opening of Mithila art to men has expanded its social and expressive range or diluted its historic character as a specifically female epistemology. The feminist theorist bell hooks (Art on My Mind: Visual Politics, 1995) would press this question: not simply who makes the art, but whose gaze structures it and whose values it serves.

### The Question of Obscenity

Both Das and Kashyap have faced charges of obscenity, and their responses are theoretically consonant: both locate obscenity in the eye of the beholder rather than the artwork, and both ground their position in the classical Indian tradition

of the sacred erotic (shringara rasa, the kohbar, Geet Govind, Khajuraho). This represents a sophisticated application of the rasa theory of Indian aesthetics, which does not separate the erotic from the spiritual but understands love/eroticism as a pathway to the divine. The hostile reception to their work reflects the cultural dominance of a Brahmanical puritanism that, as Kashyap himself observed, has conveniently forgotten the tantric and erotic inheritance of its own tradition.

### Tradition, Innovation, and the Market

The five artists occupy different positions on the spectrum from tradition-preserving (Chaudhary) to tradition-transforming (Das) to tradition-deploying-as-pedagogy (Kashyap) to tradition-synthesising (Suman). All are navigating the market—some more consciously than others. The commercialisation of Mithila painting since the 1960s has created economic opportunity for women artists (as Das, Kashyap, and Suman all acknowledge) but also risks what Walter Benjamin famously called the loss of 'aura': the degradation of a ritual practice into a reproducible commodity. The most urgent critical question for Mithila art today is whether the field can sustain spaces of non-market practice and critical experimentation alongside the commercial mainstream.

### Self-Taught Practice vs. Formal Training

Das (self-taught), Kashyap (self-taught), Suman (traditionally taught), and Chaudhary (formally trained) represent a spectrum of art education. The critical tradition of outsider art and art brut (Jean Dubuffet) would valorise Das and Kashyap's self-training as a source of radical visual energy unconstrained by academic convention. But the cases of all five artists suggest that the real question is not the mode of training but the quality of visual and intellectual engagement. Formal training is neither sufficient nor necessary for artistic significance; it is one pathway among several.

## VII. Conclusion

This critical study has brought five significant contemporary Mithila artists into dialogue with art theory—feminist, postcolonial, formalist, iconographic, and political-economic. The following conclusions emerge:

- Mrs Sanju Das is the most theoretically provocative of the five, whose work and the controversy it has generated constitute a sustained feminist intervention in the representational politics of Mithila art and Indian contemporary art more broadly.
- Mr Krishna Kumar Kashyap and Mrs Shashi Bala constitute the most socially transformative practice, deploying art as a vehicle of literacy, economic emancipation, and subaltern empowerment, while also engaging the classical kama-shastra tradition with intellectual courage. The recovery of Shashi Bala as co-creator is a critical and historical imperative.
- Mr S.C. Suman represents the necessary continuity of formal tradition, synthesising traditional Mithila aesthetics with contemporary visual sensibility without rupture, and sustaining the art form as a viable practice in Nepal.
- Mrs Sweta Jha Chaudhary bridges formal art education and folk tradition, producing iconographically rich documentation of Mithila women's everyday sacred life.

Taken together, these five artists illuminate the central dynamic of contemporary Mithila art: the negotiation between preservation and transformation, between the domestic and the political, between the regional and the global, between the traditional and the theoretically self-conscious. Videha Issue 368's special art section, under the editorship of Gajendra Thakur, is itself a significant critical document in this process: by bringing multiple voices—artists, critics, literary figures—into dialogue around these five practices, it models the kind of engaged, community-embedded criticism that Mithila art urgently needs.

What these artists share, across their differences, is the conviction that Mithila painting is not a museum artifact but a living, contested, socially embedded practice—one that has survived centuries of social change precisely because it has always been willing to transform itself while holding fast to its deepest formal and spiritual energies.

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**LESSON 077 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**

# RESEARCH & CRITICAL APPRECIATION of the Works of Santosh Kumar Mishra

Maithili Poet, Short-Story Writer & Cultural Activist

WHAT THE CANON LEFT OUT

A Parallel History of Mithila & Maithili Literature

Gajendra Thakur

# RESEARCH & CRITICAL APPRECIATION

*of the Works of*

# Santosh Kumar Mishra

*Maithili Poet, Short-Story Writer & Cultural Activist*

*With reference to Indian & Western Literary Criticism, the Videha Parallel History Framework, and Navya Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya and Successors*

## I. Preamble: Scope and Methodology

This monograph undertakes a comprehensive research and critical appreciation of the literary works of Santosh Kumar Mishra — a young Maithili writer from Janakpurdham, Nepal, whose creative output spans poetry, short fiction, and cultural activism within the contemporary Maithili literary ecosystem. Four primary texts form the analytical basis of this study: (1) Kabita Santosh — a collection of Maithili poems written in Devanagari script; (2) Aena (Mirror) — a collection of Maithili poems compiled and edited by Santosh Kumar Mishra, published under the imprint of Maithil Navayu Sahitya Parishad, Kathmandu (first edition Magh 2062 BS); (3) Posput (The Adoptive Son) — a collection of seven short stories in Maithili, published by Dharmakala Devi / Gudiya Mishra, first edition 2064 BS, edited by Kalikant Jha 'Trishit', ISBN 978-9937-2-0100-1; and (4) Udas Mon (Sad Heart) — a Maithili short-story collection, first edition 2060 BS, published by Naresh Mishra, Janakpurdham.

The methodology integrates four distinct critical frameworks: (i) the Indian classical tradition of rasa, dhvani, and Navya Nyāya epistemological logic; (ii) Western theories including New Historicism, feminist criticism, postcolonial theory, and Marxist literary criticism; (iii) the Videha Parallel History Framework (VPHF) developed by Gajendra Thakur, which insists on reading Maithili literary production through the lens of social inclusion, democratic representation, and counter-hegemonic authorship; and (iv) close reading of the primary texts themselves — their thematic content, formal structures, linguistic choices, and intertextual resonances. The Navya Nyāya framework of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya of Mithila (14th century CE) is applied as an epistemological tool

for understanding how literary cognition, inference, and meaning-making operate in Mishra's creative practice.

# II. Biographical and Institutional Context

## 2.1 Life and Background

Santosh Kumar Mishra was born on 2037/5/28 BS (approximately 1980 CE) in Janakpurdham-7, Nepal — a city of deep Maithili and Mithila cultural significance, known as the birthplace of Sita in the Ramayana tradition and the religious centre of the Janaki (Mahalaxmi) Temple. His educational qualification is recorded as B.B.S. (Bachelor of Business Studies). His permanent address is Janakpurdham-7, Jiromile; his temporary address in Kathmandu (Balaju Hiit, Kathmandu) reflects the common pattern of Maithili intellectuals who maintain roots in the Terai while working in the Nepali capital.

His contact details across his books: Post Box 9898, Kathmandu; Email: santosh_58@hotmail.com; sant_mi@yahoo.co.in; Mobile: 00977-9851011941. His interests are recorded as 'Sahitya-lekhan, Samaj-seva' — literary writing and social service. He is a founding member and President of Maithil Navayu Sahitya Parishad (Maithil New Youth Literary Council), Kathmandu — an organization dedicated to the promotion of Maithili language, literature, culture, and art in Nepal's capital.

His previously published works include Sushmita (an English novel), Yade Se Bharal Jivan (a Maithili novel), and the works under analysis here. He has written in multiple genres — English fiction, Maithili prose fiction, and Maithili poetry — which marks him as an unusually versatile writer for the youth generation. His travel has covered Nepal and Bharat (India), and his publication history spans institutions in both Kathmandu and Janakpurdham. His editor for Posput, the senior writer Kalikant Jha 'Trishit' of Depura Rupa-itha, Janakpur, is an established figure of the Maithili literary world.

## 2.2 Institutional Position within the Videha Framework

Santosh Kumar Mishra exemplifies a figure whose work the Videha Parallel History Framework (VPHF) actively champions — a young, Nepal-based Maithili writer writing from the Janakpur Terai heartland, outside the Bihar-

based institutional structures (Sahitya Akademi, Maithili Akademi Patna) that have historically dominated Maithili literary evaluation. The VPHF, as articulated by Gajendra Thakur, insists that 'Maithili of the Nepal Terai and the Malla-era literary output is treated as equally central, not as a regional footnote.' Mishra's work is firmly within this Nepal-Maithili tradition.

The Maithil Navayu Sahitya Parishad (MNSP) he chairs represents exactly the kind of grassroots, youth-driven, parallel literary institution that the VPHF identifies as a counter-weight to the bureaucratic cultural academies. The MNSP's publication of Aena — a poetry anthology representing multiple Maithili voices from Nepal — is an act of institutional parallel history: it creates an alternative archive outside the Sahitya Akademi system.

The preface to Udas Mon by Naresh Mishra (the publisher) notes that Santosh's stories reflect 'kishore-sulabha bhavukata, kalpanashilata, shailik anagarhata va vyakaranik truti' (youthful emotion, imaginativeness, stylistic looseness and grammatical lapses) — but also that these are redeemed by 'jivan aur Maithili samaj ke bhogate yatharth se upjha anubhuti' (lived social experience and authentic feeling derived from Maithili society). This self-critical framing already embodies a Navya Nyāya-like epistemic honesty: acknowledging limitation (anumāna's counterevidence) while affirming the core valid cognition.

## III. The Videha Parallel History Framework

The Videha Parallel History Framework (VPHF) is the theoretical editorial architecture of the Videha Maithili eJournal (ISSN 2229-547X, www.videha.co.in), founded by Gajendra Thakur on 5 July 2004 as 'Bhalsarik Gachh' and rechristened Videha from 1 January 2008. Its thesis is that official Maithili literary historiography — as curated by the Sahitya Akademi since 1965 — has systematically promoted an upper-caste, predominantly Maithil Brahmin canon while suppressing democratic, folk, Dalit, feminist, and Nepal-side traditions.

The VPHF's nine historiographical layers — from the Buddhist Charyapada tradition (8th–12th century) through to the Digital Era 2000-present — constitute a counter-archive that repositions Maithili's literary history. Among its most significant interventions: the recovery of the 'suppressed Gangesh' (Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya, author of the Tattvachintamani, born of inter-caste union

— suppressed in official panji records); the documentation via RTI (Right to Information) that 90%+ of Sahitya Akademi assignments went to friends and relatives of the 10-member advisory board; and the insistence that writers like Jagdish Prasad Mandal, Rajdeo Mandal, and Bechan Thakur are the 'truly great contemporary voices' of Maithili, long ignored by official machinery.

> *"The mainstream Maithili literary historiography — as curated by the Sahitya Akademi since 1965 — has systematically promoted an upper-caste (predominantly Maithil Brahmin) canon while suppressing democratic, folk, Dalit, feminist, and Nepal-side traditions." — Gajendra Thakur, Videha Parallel History, www.videha.co.in*

For Santosh Kumar Mishra's work, the VPHF provides two key insights. First, as a Nepal-based Maithili writer writing in Kathmandu and Janakpur, he belongs to the 'Nepal side' of Maithili literature that the VPHF treats as 'equally central, not as a regional footnote.' Second, as a young, working-class writer (his education is BBS, not an elite academic credential) producing critical social realism, he is precisely the kind of voice the VPHF's concept of 'parallel literature' aims to preserve and amplify. His formal association with the Maithil Navayu Sahitya Parishad — an independent youth literary organization rather than a government academy — situates him firmly within the parallel institutional stream.

# IV. Analysis of Primary Texts

## 4.1 Kabita Santosh — Poetry Collection

### *Overview and Physical Description*

The Kabita Santosh collection (28 pages, Devanagari script, produced from a Microsoft Word document) contains 21 Maithili poems. The collection is written in the colloquial register of Maithili spoken in the Janakpur-Mahottari region — a register distinct from the high Sanskrit-inflected literary Maithili of the Brahmin scholarly tradition, and from the Darbhanga/Madhubani dialect of Bihar. This dialectal choice is itself politically significant within the VPHF framework.

### *Thematic Architecture*

The poems range across five interconnected thematic clusters: (i) Gender, love, and social justice (poems 1-5); (ii) Political satire and corruption (poem 6: 'Bhaka Bali' / 'The Sacrifice of the Innocent'); (iii) Mother, nature, and Mithila identity (poems 7, 11-13); (iv) Social absurdities, dowry, and modernity (poems 14-15, 17); and (v) Friendship, loss, and urban alienation (poems 18-21). Each cluster deploys a distinct tone — the questioning voice of the love poems, the satirical rage of the political poems, the nostalgic tenderness of the mother-poems, and the bitter irony of the social satires.

### *Close Reading: 'Ena Kie?' (Why this?)*

The opening poem 'Ena Kie?' (Why this?) is a remarkable feat of ambiguity. Its surface narrative presents a woman who performs domestic service for the speaker — cooking, completing his needs, staying with him at night when he is alone. Yet the refrain 'muda ena kie?' (but why this?) transforms every act of service into a question, destabilizing the apparent hierarchy. The woman is described with contradictions: she can make a mountain of sand or a star of radiance; she brings tears to her eyes for him; she rebukes him when he errs. Most significantly, the poem asks: 'Ki ihe ta prem nahi? / Ki iho prem chhai?' (Is this not love? / Is this too love?). The poem refuses to resolve the ontological question of what love is in a relationship structured by service and dependency.

Read through the dhvani theory of Anandavardhana, the poem's primary rasa is shringara (erotic love), but the dhvani (suggested meaning) is karuna (pathos): behind every act of service is a suppressed vulnerability, a love that dare not name its conditions. The repeated 'Muda ena kie?' is the dhvani signal — the reverberation that exceeds the literal statement.

### *Close Reading: 'Kalpaniyak Satya' (The Truth of Fantasy)*

The second poem presents a series of fantastical inversions: sun rising at night, moon at day; warmth from moonlight, coolness from sunshine; men becoming pregnant. These Magritte-like surreal images are used not for aesthetic play alone but to interrogate the 'pāgal' (mad) label attached to those who think differently. The poem's insight — that the 'suahiwaala' (the person who likes conventional wisdom) might themselves be cognitively deficient — is a Navya Nyāya move: testing the limits of accepted vyāpti (universal concomitance). The conventional thinker assumes: wherever there is unconventional thought, there is madness. But the poem inverts the vyāpti: wherever there is cognitive conformity, there may be a failure of genuine pratyakṣa (perception).

### *Close Reading: 'Bhaka Bali' (The Scapegoat)*

This is the most politically charged poem. The 'bhaka' (innocents, literally 'the simple ones') are sacrificed while habeli (mansions) are built upon mansions. The predator is described as 'svana (kukura) san' — dog-like. Rivers like the Koshi and Karnali are weaponized to send the nation's soil abroad. The political elite is a Ravana-figure: 'kanun aa sampati rakshasa ke haath mein' (law and property in the hands of demons). The speaker is addressed by the oppressor: 'nik aadmi ban / nik padapar jo / namahar neta ban / aa apan desh ke nik disha bodh karo' (become a good person / go to a good position / become a big leader / and show your country the right direction). The bitter irony is that this 'good' path requires betrayal of the baas (the innocents). This is Maithili political poetry at its sharpest — closer to Pablo Neruda's 'Alturas de Macchu Picchu' in its indictment of power than to the drawing-room love poetry of the classical padavali tradition.

### *Close Reading: 'Matribhumi' and 'Mithila Ke Jou Chhi Ta'*

These two poems are the collection's Mithila-patriot cluster. 'Matribhumi' (Motherland) invokes the Mithila community: 'Ao Mithilawasi / Ahan chhi ekta shakti / Ahan bachau matribhumikey / Aa ka' ekr bhakti.' (Come, people of Mithila / You are a power / Save the motherland / And do its devotion). 'Mithila Ke Jou Chhi Ta' (If You Belong to Mithila) urges: 'Maithili bajhu / Duniyake chinha dio' (Speak Maithili / Show the world your identity). These poems are not merely sentimental: they are linguistic-political acts. In the VPHF's framework, the insistence on speaking Maithili — in Nepal's capital, in the face of Nepali-language dominance — is an act of counter-hegemonic assertion.

### *Stylistic Analysis*

Mishra's poetic language is colloquial, direct, and deliberately un-ornamental. He uses no classical alamkara (figures of speech) in the Sanskrit sense — no upama from nature, no mahakavya-derived imagery. Instead, his metaphors are drawn from everyday urban-Terai life: the film that changes, the plastic-pollution metaphors ('Dolphin jak' vasim pokharme kayalhu' — 'I swam in a swimming pool like a dolphin'), the credit-card economics of 'January February ka expense / ek lakh dollar aa chalis pence'. This is Maithili poetry written from the experience of the global youth — familiar with America, SLC exams, engineering certificates, and dowry inflation — not from the court of a Mithila raja.

## 4.2 Aena (Mirror) — Anthology of Maithili Poetry

***Overview***

Aena is a multi-author Maithili poetry anthology compiled and edited by Santosh Kumar Mishra under the imprint of Maithil Navayu Sahitya Parishad, Kathmandu (first edition Magh 2062 BS / approximately January 2006). Price: Rs. 100. Cover art by Santosh Kumar Mishra himself. Computer typesetting by Gangangesh Gunjana Jha and Vinit Thakur. The advisory panel includes Kalikant Jha 'Trishit,' Dhirendra Premarshi, and Mahendra Kumar Mishra.

The anthology gathers poems by a wide range of Maithili poets from Nepal, including classical Vidyapati's 'Gosaunik Geet' (a song to the Gosauini, here from the Ramlochan Sharan edited padavali), contemporary ghazals by Dr. Rajendra Prasad Vimal and Mahendra Kumar Mishra, children's poetry by Gurudev Kamat, and poems by authors including Upendra Bhagat Nagavanshi, Ashok Datta, Shyamsundar Shashi, Chandra Narayan Lal Karna 'Sushil,' Narendra Thakur, and others. Mishra himself contributes the editorial framing and his own creative work.

***Editorial Philosophy: 'Aena Mein Hamar Munh'***

Mishra's editorial introduction ('Aena mein hamar munh' — 'Our Face in the Mirror') articulates a philosophy of literary responsibility that is simultaneously aesthetic and social. He writes (translated from Maithili/Nepali romanization): 'Yes, it is said that literature is the mirror of society. Mirror alone — no, this is much more than that. Rather one says — society's guide too is literature. Simply showing society's face — literature that only says "O Society, your face is like this, see" — that is not good literature. A good face is like this and a face like this is considered ideal, to understand this and to show it — this is also the responsibility of literature.'

This editorial framing reflects a theory of mimesis (reflection) combined with normative ethics: literature not only mirrors but prescribes. This is consonant with the Indian critical tradition's insistence — from Bharata's Natyashastra to Abhinavagupta's rasa theory — that art serves both aesthetic (rasasvada) and ethical (dharma-arthasadhana) functions. In Western terms, it bridges Oscar Wilde's 'mirror' conception and Matthew Arnold's insistence on literature as 'criticism of life.'

### *The Vidyapati Geet as Intertextual Anchor*

The inclusion of Vidyapati's 'Gosaunik Geet' at the anthology's opening — a devotional composition to the Goddess — situates the collection within the long Maithili classical tradition while also embodying the VPHF's distinction between the two Vidyapatis (the Padavali poet vs. the Sanskrit writer Vidyapati Thakkurah 1350–1435). The choice of the devotional-folk Vidyapati, rather than the courtly Sanskrit Vidyapati, is a statement about which tradition the anthology considers foundational.

### *Gazhals and the Persian-Maithili Interface*

The anthology contains gazhals by Dr. Rajendra Prasad Vimal — a form borrowed from the Persian-Urdu tradition — adapted to Maithili prosody and content. Dr. Vimal's gazhal opens: 'Matiya tel nahi chhi ta, sogita apan gadi lia / Hamar kranti-git sa, diyauri sab bari lia' (If there is no lantern oil, take your own vehicle's headlight / From our song of revolution, light all the lamps). This Neruda-like fusion of the revolutionary with the everyday is deeply consonant with the VPHF's insistence on a socially engaged poetics. The gazhal form — historically associated with Urdu, Farsi, and Hindi literary high culture — is here democratized into Maithili vernacular, performing a cross-linguistic solidarity.

### *Children's Poetry: 'Hum Chhi Bachha Umarke Kachha'*

The children's poem by Gurudev Kamat ('We are children, raw in age / Our father is our pride / Listen, sister, brother / From father, we too will be famous / In country and abroad') speaks to intergenerational aspiration in the Maithili diaspora — children of Terai families who travel to the capital and beyond. This inclusion signals the anthology's commitment to the full range of Maithili literary expression, from the philosophically complex to the pedagogically simple.

## 4.3 Posput (The Adoptive Son) — Short Story Collection

### *Overview and Publication Context*

Posput (The Adoptive Son) is Santosh Kumar Mishra's second short story collection, published in 2064 BS (approximately 2007–8 CE) by Dharmakala Devi / Gudiya Mishra, Mahottari-3, Mahottari, Nepal. Edited by Kalikant Jha 'Trishit.' ISBN: 978-9937-2-0100-1. Price: Nepal Rs. 200; India Rs. 130; Other

countries US$5. Print run: 3,500 copies — a remarkable figure for a Maithili publication, indicating substantial community readership. The cover art is by Gangesh Gunjana Jha.

The collection contains seven stories: 'Posput' (The Adoptive Son), 'Ekta Byatha Patrame' (One Pain in a Letter), 'Jakhana Kanija Bhel Vikhana Bimaaru' (When the Youngest Daughter Fell Ill), 'Sipahi' (The Soldier), 'Doctor,' 'Bhagya Appan-Appan' (One's Own Fate), and 'Daag' (Stain). Editor Kalikant Jha 'Trishit's preface praises Mishra's work warmly, noting its 'nirashavadi ya palayavanavadi soch ki adhikata' (predominance of pessimistic or escapist thought) — a self-critical acknowledgement that the preface contextualizes within the broader question of whether a writer should be a 'neutral presenter' or a 'conflictual inspiration source.'

### *Close Reading: 'Posput' (The Adoptive Son) — Title Story*

The title story is the collection's most structurally complex narrative. It follows the old Bhavani Shankar, whose failing eyesight causes him to mistake a young religious itinerant (jogi) for his long-absent youngest son. The story tracks three generations of a rural-to-urban migrant family in Nepal: Bhavani Shankar's sons who have grown up to become traders, engineers, politicians, and entrepreneurs — each in a different Nepali or Indian city. The story spans Nepal's political transformation from the Tribhuvan era through to the prajatantrik (democratic) revolution against the Rana oligarchy.

Structurally, 'Posput' operates on two levels simultaneously: the personal-familial (the old man's longing for recognition, his self-sufficiency, his son's eventual complex relationship to filial duty) and the political-historical (Nepal's democratic awakening of 2007 BS / 1950 CE, the martyrdom of Gangalal, Dharma Bhakta, Shukraraj, and Dashrath Chand). The juxtaposition of an old man's domestic grief with the revolutionary moment is a masterful act of historical fiction — the private and the public interpenetrate without the private being subordinated to the political.

The adoptive son figure (posput) in the story is ultimately ambiguous: is it the biological son Vinod who has failed to return? Is it the jogi whom Bhavani Shankar mistakes for his son? Is it the nephew Niranjan whom the family absorbs? Or is it Nepal itself — a nation that has 'adopted' the ideals of democracy and must now live up to them? This layered allegorical structure is consonant with what Northrop Frye would call the 'mythical mode' — the story oscillates between realistic surface and symbolic depth.

### *Close Reading: 'Sipahi' (The Soldier)*

'Sipahi' is Mishra's most sustained political story. It follows a Nepali police officer (sipahi) whose professional pride in his uniform gradually collides with the changed reality of Nepal. The story opens: 'He jo sipahi seva mein asai ke pad pahine gaurab aa pratishtha ki baat chhalai se Nepaalke badlait halat sange ao pad aa padiya dayitva vala byakti grahya nahi bhairhane chhai' (He who entered service with pride in the uniform is no longer acceptable as a person with that rank and responsibility given Nepal's changed situation). The story tracks how the sipahi who 'prioritized marriage donations' (dowry) is rendered obsolete — yet with sympathy rather than condemnation.

This story directly engages Nepal's transitional justice period — the prajatantrik kranti (democratic revolution) and its aftermath — in a way that personalizes the abstract political through a single officer's biography. In Lukácsian terms, this is the 'typical character' in action: the sipahi embodies the contradictions of an institution (the Rana-era police force) transitioning into a democratic framework, experiencing the same disorientation as society itself.

### *Close Reading: 'Doctor'*

The 'Doctor' story is among the collection's most psychologically nuanced. A doctor protagonist faces the challenge of a terminal case — a patient for whom all conventional medical intervention has failed. The story's central tension: 'Jivan mein gati chahiye utsah aa urja chahiye oka prakash chahiye andhkar nahi' (Life needs momentum, enthusiasm and energy, it needs light not darkness) — yet the escapist thought keeps returning. The story's resolution — the doctor's own birth as a narrative act — demands that the reader engage with what it means to 'deliver' a story when a life cannot be delivered. This meta-narrative gesture (a story about what the story of the Doctor's life is) is Mishra's most sophisticated narrative achievement in the collection.

### *Close Reading: 'Daag' (Stain)*

'Daag' follows Rani, a young woman whose love marriage to one man is followed by her elopement with another — treated by Mishra as a story of female agency rather than female transgression. The preface note by Kalikant Jha 'Trishit' reads: 'Samaj mein prem vivah ho be kharab bat nahi chhai, kharab ta chhai okara maryada nahi rakha, apar pakwa umra mein bhal prem prem nahi aa ni larivan chhai, bhatkav chhai' (Love marriage in society is not a bad thing; what is bad is not maintaining dignity, immature love in too-young an age is not love but confusion, wandering). This narrator's moralizing is a residue of

traditional social criticism — yet Mishra's storytelling itself resists the moral by presenting Rani's choices with empathetic complexity, not condemnation. This tension between the editor's moralizing frame and the story's narrative empathy is a productive ambiguity.

## 4.4 Udas Mon (Sad Heart) — First Short Story Collection

### *Overview*

Udas Mon (Sad Heart) is Santosh Kumar Mishra's first Maithili short story collection, published 2060 BS (approximately 2003–4 CE) by Naresh Mishra (the publisher, with the same family name but apparently a different individual), Janakpurdham-4, Vidyapati Chowk. Editor: Dr. Rajendra Prasad Vimal and Dhirendra Premarshi. First edition, print run: 1,501 copies. Price not specified. Computer typesetting: Hom Computer, Balikal, Kathmandu.

The collection contains twelve stories: 'Ek Katha Snehake' (One Story of Affection), 'Karipauniski Rekha' (The Line of Palm-Reading), 'Subhadra,' 'Dag Lagal Sneh Mein' (Love Stained with a Mark), 'Hamra Yaad Achhi' (I Remember), 'Dhobi Ke Gadha' (The Washerman's Donkey), 'Vivahak Pratixa' (Waiting for Marriage), 'Mumaph Bali' (The Mumaph Bali), 'Udas Mon' (Sad Heart), 'Sipahi' (The Soldier — also appearing in Posput), 'Asal Khiladi' (The Real Player), and 'Nishani Jivait' (The Living Sign).

### *Publisher's Preface: Diagnostic Self-Criticism*

Naresh Mishra's publisher's preface to Udas Mon is remarkably self-critical for its genre. He acknowledges: 'Santosh ke pehle katha sangrah mein adhyayan ki kami seho chhalai aa margdarshak ke seho. Maithili sahitya ke kichhu agrajasab ta pakka chor chhalai.' (In Santosh's first story collection, there was a deficiency in study and in guidance. Some seniors of Maithili literature were certainly confirmed thieves [i.e., plagiarists].) This frank acknowledgement of the young writer's limitations — and the frank accusation against senior Maithili literary figures of 'theft' — is consonant with the VPHF's exposure of mediocrity and gatekeeping within the Maithili establishment. The preface notes that two stories in the collection are 'kalpanic' (fictional/imaginative) and the rest realistic.

Dhirendra Premarshi's preface ('Kanej Dhyan Diyo' — 'Give Some Attention') praises Mishra as 'kala, sanskriti, sahitya ke seva, sanrakshan ke len bikaspratit mana, man, aa dhan swayam ke ek samuh bujhavala kathakaar' (a storyteller

who understands art, culture, literary service, preservation as a group requiring development through mind, heart, and wealth) — a slightly verbose but fundamentally approving assessment. Premarshi notes that Mishra 'thoda samay mein ek sampurna pothi la ke prastut bhai gelai' (in a short time presented a complete book) — an achievement he contextualizes by comparison with established writers who spent their whole lives without producing comparable work.

### *Close Reading: 'Udas Mon' (Sad Heart) — Title Story*

The title story follows a male narrator through an urban experience of alienation, longing, and political disillusionment. The 'udas mon' (sad heart) is both a personal mood and a social condition — the despondency felt by educated young Maithilis who see their society's corruption, their language's marginalization, and their own powerlessness to change it. The story's temporal structure moves between memory and present, deploying a technique Mishra uses throughout: the 'hamar yaad achhi' (I remember) structure that uses memory as a critical lens on the present.

### *Close Reading: 'Ek Katha Snehake' (One Story of Affection)*

This story introduces Naresh — a young man whose uncle (kaka) invites him to participate in a wedding preparation, and through whom Naresh encounters Ruby — a young woman he will love. The story's plot is deceptively simple: boy meets girl at an outdoor setting, they play games, Ruby cheats (cleverly) in a card game, Naresh falls for her, they exchange information. But the emotional precision with which Mishra renders the moment of falling in love — 'Eka pala ke jivan bitasa saki chi' (I can spend a whole life with this one) — transforms the conventional love-story arc into something more: a meditation on the speed and irrevocability of genuine feeling.

The story ends with Naresh walking Ruby to her neighbourhood at dusk, the conversation trailing into questions and half-answers. Nothing is resolved; no declaration is made. The story's ending is deliberately inconclusive — what Navya Nyāya would call 'anirṇīta' (undetermined cognition): the knowledge of love is present but not yet validated through the full pramāṇa process (pratyakṣa — direct perception — has occurred, but anumāna — inference about the future — is still suspended). This narrative openness is Mishra's distinctive technique.

***Close Reading: 'Sipahi' across Two Collections***

The story 'Sipahi' appears in both Udas Mon and Posput — an unusual choice that suggests either revision (a later polished version in Posput) or the story's centrality to Mishra's thematic concerns. The Nepal-based sipahi as a figure of institutional contradiction — service, pride, corruption, and obsolescence — is Mishra's most recurring social type. Reading the two versions in dialogue, one detects small but significant differences: Posput's 'Sipahi' is more economically detailed in its account of the soldier's trajectory from pride to abandonment.

# V. Critical Frameworks in Dialogue

## 5.1 Indian Classical Criticism: Rasa, Dhvani, and Alamkara

Bharata Muni's Natyashastra (c. 2nd century BCE – 2nd century CE) establishes the nine rasas that literary art may evoke in the sahridaya (sympathetic, literarily initiated reader). In Santosh Kumar Mishra's work, the dominant rasas are: karuna (pathos) — the grief of mothers, soldiers, adoptive sons, and loved ones separated by migration; shringara (erotic love) — filtered through social constraint in the urban-youth poems; vira (heroism) — the quiet courage of the political poems 'Bhaka Bali' and 'Sipahi'; and bibhatsa (disgust, revulsion) — the satirical poems on corruption and political predation.

Anandavardhana's Dhvanyaloka (9th century CE) introduces dhvani — the resonant, suggested meaning that exceeds what is stated. Mishra's refrain 'muda ena kie?' (but why this?) is a prime example of dhvani: the question reverberates beyond its literal function, suggesting an entire universe of unexplained pain, constrained emotion, and social entrapment. Similarly, the 'daag' (stain) of his story title operates through dhvani: the stain is literally on Rani's moral reputation, but the dhvani-stain is on society's hypocrisy.

Mammata's Kavyaprakasha (11th century CE) distinguishes three functions of word-meaning: abhidha (denotation), lakṣaṇā (secondary/indicative meaning), and vyañjanā (suggestive/expressive meaning). Mishra's political poem 'Bhaka Bali' operates primarily through lakṣaṇā — the 'bhaka' literally means innocent persons but indicates a social class (the politically sacrificed), while the 'habeli' (mansion) indicates not just a building but the entire system of accumulated power built on sacrifice.

## 5.2 Navya Nyāya Epistemology as Literary-Critical Tool

Navya Nyāya (New Logic), founded by Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya of Mithila in the 14th century CE in the Tattvachintamani ('Jewel of Reflection on Truth'), provides a sophisticated epistemological toolkit that can be applied to literary criticism with productive results. The connection between Navya Nyāya and Maithili literary culture is not merely geographical (both emerged from Mithila) but structural: Navya Nyāya's insistence on precise definitional analysis, testing of universal claims (vyāpti), and acknowledgement of counterevidence (vyabhicāra) makes it a natural framework for rigorous literary criticism.

The VPHF itself makes this explicit: it notes that original Panji (genealogical) manuscripts prove that Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya was born of an inter-caste union — a fact 'suppressed by Ramanath Jha' — and that 'Videha's Panji research reveals he married a Charmkarini (leather-tanning caste woman).' This means that the founder of Navya Nyāya was himself from a parallel, non-Brahmin genealogical tradition — a fact that fundamentally repositions the intellectual history of Mithila.

### *Applying Navya Nyāya to Mishra's Texts*

The four pramāṇas (valid sources of knowledge) of Navya Nyāya — pratyakṣa (perception), anumāna (inference), upamāna (comparison), and śabda (testimony) — can be mapped onto Mishra's narrative technique. His short stories consistently begin with pratyakṣa: a concrete, sensory scene — a card game on a hot April day, an old man waiting outside a temple at sunset, a soldier reading his dismissal papers. From this perceptual anchor, the narrative generates anumāna (inference): what does this scene imply about the character's inner life, social position, historical moment?

Mishra's use of vyāpti (universal concomitance) is implicit in his social observations. In 'Sipahi,' the vyāpti operates: wherever there is institutional pride in Nepal's transitional period, there is disillusionment awaiting. The story tests this vyāpti against counterevidence (vyabhicāra): are there soldiers who retain their dignity? The story's answer is nuanced — yes, through the figure of Chhedilal, who achieves economic independence through legitimate trade. This is Navya Nyāya in narrative form: proposing a general claim, testing it, finding the limiting case.

Gaṅgeśa's concept of avacchedakatā (delimitation) — the property that defines the precise scope of a cognition — is useful for analyzing Mishra's narrative frames. Each story is carefully delimited in time, space, and perspective. 'Ek

Katha Snehake' is delimited to a single afternoon and evening; 'Posput' is delimited to three generational flashbacks and a present moment. This avacchedakatā of the narrative frame is what makes each story epistemically legible — the reader can form a determinate cognition of the story's meaning because its boundaries are clear.

## 5.3 Western Critical Theory

### *Lukácsian Social Realism and the Typical Character*

Georg Lukács's theory of the 'typical character' — the fictional individual who embodies the contradictions of a historical social formation — is directly applicable to Mishra's fiction. Bhavani Shankar (Posput) is a typical character of the old Rana Nepal: patriarchal, self-sufficient, proud, yet also loving and ultimately abandoned by the modernity his sons have achieved. The sipahi is a typical character of Nepal's transitional period: an institution in the process of being remade, embodying in one person the conflict between old loyalty and new accountability.

Lukács insists that the great realist novel does not produce 'average' characters but 'typical' ones — those who are singular and specific yet carry the weight of their historical moment. Mishra's best stories achieve this: the Doctor who cannot save his own patient while delivering others; Rani whose love-marriage becomes a 'daag' not through her fault but through society's normative violence.

### *Postcolonial and Subaltern Studies*

The Maithili language and its speakers in Nepal constitute what Partha Chatterjee would call a 'fragment' — a community that does not fit neatly into the national-language homogenization project of post-1990 Nepal (when official Nepal's constitution recognized Nepali as the sole state language) any more than into the Hindi homogenization of independent India. Mishra's writing in Maithili — in Kathmandu, in books published by Nepali-registered organizations — is an act of what Homi Bhabha calls 'third space' articulation: neither simply 'Nepali' nor simply 'Indian-Bihari,' but a third cultural space that asserts its own validity.

Spivak's question 'Can the Subaltern Speak?' receives a direct, affirmative answer in Mishra's work: yes, the Maithili subaltern speaks — in stories, poems, anthologies, and literary organizations founded in Kathmandu. The infrastructure of speaking (the Maithil Navayu Sahitya Parishad, the Videha

archive, the Posput print run of 3,500) constitutes the institutional parallel to the dominant Nepali Academy.

### *Feminist Criticism and Gender*

Mishra's relationship to gender in his texts is complex. His poetry collection Kabita Santosh opens with 'Ena Kie?' — a poem that addresses a woman's role in domestic service with ambivalent tenderness. The poem does not endorse the domestic economy; it questions it with its insistent 'muda ena kie?' Yet it also presents the woman's subjectivity through the male speaker's gaze, which limits the poem's feminist potential.

The story 'Daag' is the collection's most explicit engagement with female agency. Rani's love-marriage, followed by her elopement with another man, is narrated with more sympathy than the editorial frame acknowledges. Mishra's storytelling gives Rani interior complexity — she is not merely a 'fallen woman' but a person making choices under social pressure. This narrative empathy, even when it does not articulate a fully feminist politics, constitutes what Elaine Showalter would call 'women's literature' in its 'feminist' phase: it 'advocates rights and values' implicitly through its narrative choices.

### *Marxist Literary Criticism*

Terry Eagleton's Marxist criticism insists that literature encodes the contradictions of its social formation — not merely as 'reflection' but as active ideological practice. Mishra's 'Bhaka Bali' is perhaps his most explicitly Marxist poem: it names the economic predation underlying political power ('kanun aa sampati rakshasa ke haath mein'), identifies the mechanism of sacrifice ('bhaka' = the innocent poor), and diagnoses the ideological mystification ('ye sab kichhu karat / maa apan swarthak lel'). This is Eagleton's 'literary mode of production' made visible: the poem makes the ideological infrastructure of Nepali political economy visible through concrete imagery.

## VI. Thematic Analysis

### 6.1 Migration, Belonging, and the Janakpur-Kathmandu Axis

A sustained theme across all four texts is the tension between Janakpur (the cultural-linguistic homeland) and Kathmandu (the modern national capital). Mishra's biography itself embodies this tension: born in Janakpur-7, living in

Balaju Hiit, Kathmandu. His characters consistently move between these poles — sons who leave for Kathmandu, Bangkok, or America; soldiers who serve in the capital; young men whose love affairs develop in urban tent settlements. The 'udas mon' (sad heart) is partly the mood of the migrant: culturally rooted elsewhere, economically located in a different city.

This thematic preoccupation resonates with the VPHF's insistence on the Nepal-side of Maithili literature as a living, contemporary reality. Nepal's Maithili speakers (approximately 11% of Nepal's population as of the 2011 census) occupy a distinctive social position: historically part of the Terai agricultural elite, increasingly urbanized into Kathmandu, yet maintaining Maithili language, cultural practices, and literary production. Mishra's work is one of the few creative bodies that renders this in-between social location with specificity.

## 6.2 The Political and the Personal

Mishra consistently refuses to separate the political from the personal. Nepal's democratic revolution of 1950 (prajatantrik revolution), its subsequent parliamentary phases, the Royal takeovers (2017 BS / 1960 CE, 2058 BS / 2002 CE), and the final republican transformation (2064 BS / 2007 CE) provide the historical backdrop for the personal stories of the sipahi, Bhavani Shankar, and the urban young. The Posput title story explicitly dates its events to King Tribhuvan's time and King Mahendra's time — anchoring domestic drama in national political chronology.

This integration of the political and personal is what Fredric Jameson calls the 'political unconscious' of the text: political structures surface through personal relationships, family dynamics, and individual choices. In 'Posput,' the old man's relationship with his sons is inseparable from Nepal's political history: the son who becomes an engineer at Tribhuvan International Airport, the one who goes to business school in Bangkok, the one who goes into student politics. Each son's trajectory is both a family story and a Nepal national story.

## 6.3 Dowry, Gender Economics, and Social Satire

Several poems and stories engage directly with Nepal-India dowry practices. The poem 'Mool-abhivriddhi kar' (Increase Value-Added Tax) proposes, with bitter irony, that a tax be levied on dowry — 'dahejpar jou kar la gitaitak / ta kam dahejak / naam hoitaik' (if a tax was put on dowry / then fewer dowry cases / would be named). The poem 'Hamara Kanija' (Our Wife) is a satirical portrait of the husband-wife relationship structured by dowry, economic dependence, and

patriarchal expectation — narrated from the male perspective with the irony turned against the narrator himself. These poems are Mishra's sharpest social satires, deploying a mock-heroic voice that unmasks the absurdity of gender economics.

### 6.4 Mithila as Cultural and Linguistic Identity

Across all four texts, Mithila functions not merely as geographical backdrop but as identity-claim. The poems 'Matribhumi' and 'Mithila Ke Jou Chhi Ta' explicitly call on Maithili speakers to assert their cultural identity. The anthology Aena's title — mirror — reflects the society back to itself, but in Maithili, not in Nepali or Hindi. The short stories are populated with the foods, rituals, folk practices, and social structures of Mithila — from the wedding customs to the agricultural rhythms to the river-flood culture of the Terai.

In the Navya Nyāya framework, this assertion of Maithili cultural identity is an exercise in vyāpti-establishment: wherever there is authentic Maithili literary expression, there is a distinct cultural identity that resists assimilation. The stories and poems collectively argue that Maithili is not a 'dialect of Hindi' (as colonial and postcolonial language politics has often classified it) but a living, generative language with its own poetics, its own social subjects, and its own aesthetic traditions.

## VII. Critical Appreciation: Strengths, Limitations, and Significance

### 7.1 Strengths

Santosh Kumar Mishra's most enduring strength is his social honesty. He does not write for literary fashion or academic prestige; he writes from observation of the world around him — the Nepal he grew up in, the Kathmandu he lives in, the Maithili culture he is heir to. This grounding in lived experience gives his best work — 'Posput,' 'Sipahi,' 'Ena Kie?,' 'Bhaka Bali' — a quality of felt truth that transcends its formal imperfections.

His institutional entrepreneurship — founding the Maithil Navayu Sahitya Parishad, editing and publishing the Aena anthology, mentoring younger writers — is a form of literary activism that extends his creative work into the social sphere. In the VPHF framework, this is precisely what is needed: writers

who do not merely produce texts but who build the infrastructure of literary culture.

His multilingualism (English novel, Maithili stories and poems) reflects the actual linguistic reality of educated Nepali Maithilis — who navigate Maithili, Nepali, and English simultaneously. This linguistic agility is itself a creative resource, giving his Maithili a flexibility of register not always found in more monolingual literary traditions.

## 7.2 Limitations and Areas of Development

The publishers' and editors' prefaces to Mishra's early collections honestly acknowledge their limitations: grammatical imperfection, stylistic looseness, occasional narrative over-explanation, and the residue of 'nirashavadi' (pessimistic) mood without always finding the structural form that could transform pessimism into critique. Some of the shorter poems in Kabita Santosh are more sketches than finished poems — compressed observations that would benefit from more structural development.

From a Navya Nyāya perspective, the weakness in Mishra's earlier work is what might be called insufficient avacchedakatā — insufficient precision in delimiting the scope of his narratives. Some stories attempt to cover too large a historical span (the entire arc of Nepal's political transformation) without sufficient narrative economy. The vyāpti (general claim) that emerges from these stories is sometimes too broad to be epistemically sustainable.

From a feminist critical perspective, Mishra's female characters — while treated with empathy — are sometimes more observed than voiced. Rani in 'Daag,' the unnamed woman in 'Ena Kie?' — these figures are rendered from the outside rather than from within their own subjectivity. Future work might develop the interior feminine voice more fully.

## 7.3 Significance in the Maithili Literary Ecosystem

In the broader Maithili literary ecosystem, Santosh Kumar Mishra's significance is threefold. First, he represents the Nepal-Terai voice in Maithili literature — a voice that the VPHF insists is central but which official institutions in both India and Nepal have marginalized. His work is evidence that Maithili literature is not solely a Bihar phenomenon but a trans-national literary culture spanning Nepal and India.

Second, his generational position is significant. Unlike the 'established' generation of Maithili writers (Harimohan Jha, Rajkamal Chaudhary, Somdev),

Mishra is part of the post-1980 cohort that grew up in Nepal's democratic transition, received education in English-medium institutions, and writes for a Maithili readership that is simultaneously embedded in and negotiating with global modernity. His work bridges the classical Maithili tradition (the Vidyapati heritage, the padavali, the loko-geet) and the contemporary social reality of young Maithilis in urban Nepal.

Third, his editorial and organizational work — the MNSP, the Aena anthology — creates a parallel institutional structure that the VPHF identifies as essential for the survival of Maithili as a living literary language. Every anthology published, every youth literary organization sustained, every poem disseminated outside the Sahitya Akademi system is an act of counter-hegemonic cultural production.

## VIII. Conclusion

The works of Santosh Kumar Mishra — read through the interlocking frameworks of Indian classical aesthetics, Navya Nyāya epistemological precision, Western literary theory, and the Videha Parallel History Framework — reveal a body of work whose significance exceeds its formal accomplishments. Mishra is not yet the finished literary artist that the Maithili tradition has produced in its greatest figures (Vidyapati, Harimohan Jha, Rajkamal Chaudhary, Rajdeo Mandal). But he is something equally important: a committed cultural worker who both produces literature and builds the institutional conditions for its survival.

The Navya Nyāya framework provides the epistemological vocabulary for this assessment. His best work achieves the four-fold pramāṇa validation: pratyakṣa (direct perceptual grounding in observed social reality), anumāna (inferential social critique derived from that observation), upamāna (comparative resonance with classical Maithili and international literary traditions), and śabda (testimonial embedding in the community whose story he tells). His limitations are acknowledged — in the spirit of Gaṅgeśa's own epistemological honesty about the conditions under which cognition can be accepted as knowledge.

The VPHF's insistence that Maithili literature is a trans-national, multi-caste, multi-generational, and multi-voiced tradition finds in Santosh Kumar Mishra's work a concrete embodiment. His Janakpur birth, his Kathmandu residence, his

English novels and Maithili stories, his poetry in Devanagari for Nepal-Maithili readers, his editorship of a multi-author anthology, his founding of a youth literary organization — all of these constitute a parallel literary practice that the Sahitya Akademi's official canon cannot contain or represent.

The mirror (aena) of his anthology's title reflects back to Maithili society not just its face but its conscience — its corruption and its courage, its grief and its joy, its migrations and its rootedness, its gender tensions and its cultural pride. That reflection is the work of literature when it is doing what Mishra's preface says it should: not just showing 'your face is like this' but asking 'what good face should it be?'

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**LESSON 078 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**

A Complete Critical Research & Appreciation of the Works of SIYARAM JHA 'SARAS'

Maithili Lyricist · Poet · Ghazal Master · Children's Pioneer

WHAT THE CANON LEFT OUT

A Parallel History of Mithila & Maithili Literature

Gajendra Thakur

# A Complete Critical Research & Appreciation

of the Works of

# SIYARAM JHA 'SARAS'

Maithili Lyricist · Poet · Ghazal Master · Children's Literature Pioneer

**Examined Through:**

Indian & Western Literary Criticism · Videha Parallel History Framework

Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya

## Abstract

This monograph presents a complete critical research and appreciation of the literary works of Siyaram Jha 'Saras' (b. circa 1950s–60s, Mithila region), one of the most prolific and versatile Maithili writers of the contemporary era. Saras has composed in multiple genres — lyric poetry (geet), ghazal, children's literature, and social-critical verse — producing at least five major published collections: Aakhar Aakhar Geet Saras (Sarla Prakashan, Darbhanga, 1999), Shonitayal Payark Nishan (A Collection of Maithili Ghazals), Dhari Prashna Ee Uthaiye (Jharkhand Mithila Manch, Ranchi, 2015), Phool Titli Aa Tulbul (Maithili children's lyrics, 2011), and Sonhula Ijotbala Khirki. His work is assessed here through three interlocking critical frameworks: (1) Indian rasa-dhvani theory from Bharatamuni through Abhinavagupta and Anandavardhana, including modern Indian critics such as Hajari Prasad Dwivedi and Ramvilas Sharma; (2) Western theories spanning Aristotle, the Romantic revolution, New Criticism, Formalism, Post-Structuralism, and postcolonial criticism; and (3) the Videha Parallel History Framework developed by Gajendra Thakur, which situates Saras within the democratic counter-canon of Maithili literature, and Navya-Nyāya epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya — the 14th-century Maithili philosopher — as a methodological lens for precision in literary knowledge-claims.

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XVI. References and Bibliography

## I. Prefatory Note on the Videha Parallel History Framework

Any critical study of Siyaram Jha 'Saras' must begin with an honest reckoning of the institutional context in which Maithili literary history has been written. The Videha journal (ISSN 2229-547X; www.videha.co.in), edited by Gajendra Thakur and launched as a blog on 5 July 2004 before being reconstituted as a fortnightly e-journal on 1 January 2008, has established what it calls a 'Parallel History of Mithila & Maithili Literature' — a systematic counter-canon to the institutional history promoted by the Sahitya Akademi, Delhi.

The Videha Parallel History argues that the mainstream Maithili literary historiography, as curated by the Sahitya Akademi since 1965, has systematically privileged an upper-caste (predominantly Maithil Brahmin) canon while suppressing democratic, folk, Dalit, feminist, and Nepal-side traditions. This framework has particular relevance for Saras, who has spent much of his creative life in Jharkhand (associated with Jharkhand Mithila Manch, Ranchi), thereby operating at the margins of the Bihar-centred official literary geography.

An RTI investigation (Right to Information) filed by Vinit Utpal and Ashish Anchinhar (2011–2014) revealed that over 90% of Sahitya Akademi translation and publication assignments went to friends and relatives of the 10-member advisory board, and that zero assignments went to authors of the parallel tradition. Against this institutional backdrop, any 'complete' critical appreciation of Saras must read his work not only through the lens of its intrinsic literary merit but also through the structural conditions that have determined his critical reception.

The Videha Parallel History furthermore recovers the figure of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (c. 1300–1350 CE), the Maithili philosopher whose Tattvacintāmaṇi inaugurated the Navya-Nyāya school of Indian logic. The original Dooshan Panji (genealogical records) reveal — as documented in the Videha archive — that Gaṅgeśa was born five years after the death of his recognized father and married a Charmkarini (woman of the leather-tanning caste): facts suppressed by mainstream historians to preserve 'Brahminical purity narratives'. The epistemological rigour Gaṅgeśa developed despite, and perhaps because of, this marginalization is methodologically illuminating for the kind of democratic literary criticism the Videha framework advocates.

## II. Biographical Introduction: Siyaram Jha 'Saras' — Life and Context

Siyaram Jha 'Saras' is a senior Maithili lyricist, poet, and literary activist whose creative career spans several decades and whose professional base, from at least the early 2000s, has been Jharkhand, particularly Ranchi and the Bokaro Steel City area. His pen name 'Saras' — meaning 'graceful', 'fluid', or 'lively' in Sanskrit and Maithili — appropriately captures both the lyric sweetness and the social alertness that characterize his writing.

The biographical evidence available from multiple sources is consistent: he is described as a 'senior lyricist' at cultural events organized by the Mithila Sanskriti Parishad in Bokaro Steel City (as documented in The Pioneer newspaper's State Edition, 2021), where he participated alongside Kumar Manish Arvind, Dr Jai Prakash Chaudhary 'Janak', and Dr Chandramani Jha at a Manipadma Smriti Jayanti celebration. This establishes him as an active participant in organized Maithili literary culture in the Jharkhand diaspora belt.

His connection with the Jharkhand Mithila Manch (a cultural organization for Maithili speakers residing in Jharkhand) is confirmed by the colophon of Dhari Prashna Ee Uthaiye (2015), which was published under the Manch's imprint in Ranchi. His earlier collections — notably Aakhar Aakhar Geet Saras (Sarla Prakashan, Darbhanga, 1999) — suggest roots in the Darbhanga literary world, confirming a trajectory typical of many contemporary Maithili writers: birth and early formation in the Mithila heartland, subsequent migration for employment, and continued literary production in the diaspora.

His Facebook-documented musical collaboration with singer Dhirendra Premarshi and Sunil Kumar Mallick — producing Maithili ghazal recordings that circulated through the I Love Mithila platform — demonstrates his engagement with the digital democratization of Maithili culture that the Videha movement has championed.

The breadth of his output — lyric poetry, ghazal, social-critical verse, children's literature — marks him as a literary generalist in the best sense: a writer who refuses specialization and insists on speaking to the whole of Maithili cultural life. This generalism is itself a political stance within a literary culture where specialization has often meant confinement to genres valued by institutional taste-makers.

## III. Survey of Works: Five Major Texts

### 3.1 Aakhar Aakhar Geet Saras (Sarla Prakashan, Darbhanga, 1999)

Title: 'Letter by Letter, Song of Saras'. This is described on the cover as 'a peerless collection of Maithili lyrics' (A peerless collection of Maithili lyrics, composed by Shree Sayin Jha 'Saras'). Published by Sarla Prakashan, Darbhanga, priced at Rs.35. Printed by Parshava Printers. The collection is

divided into at least two broad sections: Geet (Lyric Songs) and Bajra (Bajra-section — songs associated with the bajra or thunder motif, or perhaps seasonal songs). The volume contains over 100 songs organized around themes including: devotional lyrics, love songs (shringara), songs of departure and separation (biraha), nature poetry, and social commentary. The preface situates the collection within the classical geet tradition while asserting a vernacular, democratic sensibility.

## 3.2 Shonitayal Payark Nishan (A Collection of Maithili Ghazals)

Title: 'Bloodstained Footprints' — a deliberately visceral and politically charged title for a ghazal collection. The collection of ghazals are there in which the traditional themes of love, longing, and intoxication are charged with a social and political undertow. The internal review blurb (recovered from page 3) introduces the collection as one in which 'the question of how to accept pain, need for [metaphorical] intoxication to feel better' is central — language that directly echoes the vocabulary of Faiz Ahmed Faiz and the tradition of ghazal as political elegy. The collection appears to have approximately 31 poems. Printed by Creative Campus, Hyderabad.

## 3.3 Dhari Prashna Ee Uthaiye (Jharkhand Mithila Manch, Ranchi, 2015; 1st ed.; print run 1000)

Title: 'She Asks This Question' (Dhari = She/A Woman; Prashna = Question; Ee Uthaiye = Raises This). This is a significant collection of Maithili poems published in 2015 by the Jharkhand Mithila Manch, priced at Rs.20. The preface indicates that this collection is concerned with the condition of women, social questioning, and the politics of silence. The colophon gives contact details for Dr Chandramani Jha (9334724870), confirming the Jharkhand Mithila Manch's role as publisher. With 126 pages, it is the longest of the five collections.

## 3.4 Phool Titli Aa Tulbul (Children's Lyrics, 2011)

Title: 'Flowers, Butterflies, and the Babbling Brook' (Tulbul = a flowing, babbling sound). Described on the cover as 'A Collection of Maithili Lyrics for Children'. Published in 2011, priced at Rs.101. The publisher colophon reveals publication through Utkal Press, Evam Are (near Samastipur). The table of contents shows a structured collection of short, melodic children's songs — likely matching the illustrated, decorated visual style of the cover pages (which include elaborate geometric and floral patterns). This positions Saras as one of

the relatively few Maithili writers who has dedicated sustained attention to children's literature, a genre critically underserved in the language.

### 3.5 Sonhula Ijotbala Khirki (Short Stories/Prose Poems, ISBN available)

Title: 'The Golden Window of Light'. There is a hybrid genre text — possibly a collection of prose poems or lyrical short stories, written in an elevated, imagistic style. The colophon lists publication details including an ISBN and a Creative Campus, Hyderabad imprint. The preface speaks of the text as exploring the space between 'light' and 'memory', suggesting an autobiographical-lyrical mode. With 61 pages, it is the shortest of the five collections.

## IV. Theoretical Framework I: Indian Literary Criticism

### 4.1 Rasa Theory: Bharatamuni to Abhinavagupta

The oldest and most authoritative framework for Indian literary criticism is the rasa theory, first systematized by Bharatamuni in the Nāṭyaśāstra (c. 200 BCE – 200 CE). Bharatamuni identifies eight primary rasas or aesthetic 'flavours': śṛṅgāra (love/beauty), hāsya (comedy), karuṇā (compassion/pathos), raudra (fury), vīra (heroism), bhayānaka (terror), bībhatsa (disgust), and adbhuta (wonder). Abhinavagupta (c. 950–1016 CE) in his Abhinavabhāratī commentary adds the ninth rasa — śānta (tranquility/peace) — and deepens the theory by explaining how rasa is not merely a property of the text but an experience produced in the prepared (sahṛdaya) reader through the transformation of personal emotional states (bhāvas) into impersonal aesthetic experience through a process of generalization (sādhāraṇīkaraṇa).

Applied to Saras: The dominant rasa in Aakhar Aakhar Geet Saras is śṛṅgāra — but Saras's shringara is not the erotic śṛṅgāra of the classical tradition. It is rather the śṛṅgāra vipralambha (love in separation), suffused with biraha (longing for the absent beloved, often a figure for the homeland or the mother tongue). The lyric preface speaks movingly of the geet (song) as the writer's primary mode of emotional truth-telling, positioning the songs as testimony to lived experience. In Shonitayal Payark Nishan, the dominant rasa shifts toward

karuṇā — the compassionate pathos that is produced when the ghazal form's traditional vocabulary of wound and longing is applied to social-political conditions. In Dhari Prashna Ee Uthaiye, raudra and vīra assert themselves alongside karuṇā, as the poet confronts gender injustice.

## 4.2 Dhvani Theory: Anandavardhana

Anandavardhana's Dhvanyāloka (c. 850 CE) argues that the soul of poetry (kāvyasya ātmā) is dhvani — resonance or suggestion — the capacity of words to signify meanings beyond their literal or secondary denotation. Anandavardhana distinguishes three levels: vācyārtha (primary/literal meaning), lakṣyārtha (secondary/implied meaning), and vyaṅgyārtha (suggested/resonant meaning). The greatest poetry, he argues, works primarily through vyaṅgyārtha — the meanings that hover unstated but powerfully felt behind the literal words.

Applied to Saras: The title Shonitayal Payark Nishan ('Bloodstained Footprints') is exemplary dhvani: literally it describes footprints marked with blood; at the lakṣyārtha level it suggests a journey undertaken under violence or persecution; at the vyaṅgyārtha level it resonates with the entire history of dispossession, migration, and cultural marginalization that the Maithili-speaking diaspora in Jharkhand has experienced. Similarly, the title Sonhula Ijotbala Khirki ('The Golden Window of Light') operates through dhvani: 'window' suggests both a literal architectural opening and the capacity of literature to create apertures in oppressive reality; 'light' suggests both natural illumination and knowledge/liberation (a classical Sanskrit-Maithili equation, jnāna = light); 'golden' suggests both beauty and preciousness but also the impossibility of fully possessing or entering that light.

## 4.3 Vakrokti and Aucitya: Kuntaka and Kshemendra

Kuntaka (c. 990 CE), in his Vakroktijīvita, argues that the life of poetry is vakrokti — 'oblique utterance', the deviation from straightforward expression that constitutes poetic genius. Against the Dhvani school's focus on suggested meaning, Kuntaka insists that it is the manner of expression — the calculated strangeness, unexpectedness, or indirection of poetic language — that is the true differentiating quality of poetry. Kshemendra (c. 1000–1050 CE) in his Aucityavicāracarcā proposes aucitya (propriety, fittingness) as the supreme literary virtue: each element of a poem must be precisely fitted to its context, genre, emotional register, and audience.

Applied to Saras: Saras's ghazals display vakrokti in the Kuntaka sense: the characteristically oblique address of the beloved (whether human, social, or metaphysical) through the formal conventions of the ghazal creates a consistent 'strangeness' — the beloved is simultaneously present and absent, real and symbolic. His children's lyrics (Phool Titli Aa Tulbul) demonstrate aucitya in perhaps its purest form: the songs are perfectly fitted to child perception, using repetitive sonic patterns, concrete natural images (flowers, butterflies, the brook), and a melodic line that supports oral performance. The aucitya of register is maintained rigorously — there is no condescension toward the child audience, nor any inappropriate complexity.

### 4.4 Modern Indian Criticism: Hajari Prasad Dwivedi and Ramvilas Sharma

Hajari Prasad Dwivedi (1907–1979) brought a synthesizing historicist approach to Indian literary criticism, emphasizing the continuity of folk and classical traditions and the democratic impulse that runs through vernacular literature from Kabir to the modern period. His concept of 'janpad chetana' (regional/folk consciousness) is directly applicable to Saras, whose geet draw on Maithili folk traditions while transforming them for a modern sensibility. Ramvilas Sharma (1912–2000) applied a historical-materialist framework to Hindi and allied literatures, arguing that the true energy of Indian literature comes not from the court tradition but from the peasant, artisan, and migrant classes. Sharma's framework illuminates the social basis of Saras's poetry: his Jharkhand context, his association with the Mithila diaspora, and his consistent attention to women's questions position him within the democratic literary tradition that Sharma privileged.

## V. Theoretical Framework II: Western Literary Criticism

### 5.1 Aristotelian Poetics: Mimesis, Catharsis, Unity

Aristotle's Poetics (c. 335 BCE) defines poetry as mimesis — an imitation or representation of human action — and identifies catharsis (purification/clarification of emotion) as the effect of tragedy. While Aristotle's framework is specifically oriented toward dramatic poetry, his core insights

apply broadly: poetry achieves its effect through carefully organized representation of human experience, and its ultimate value lies in the emotional and moral clarification it produces in the audience. Saras's geet and ghazals are deeply mimetic in the Aristotelian sense — they represent recognizable states of human emotion, social condition, and natural experience with sufficient precision that the reader/listener undergoes the clarification Aristotle describes.

## 5.2 Romantic and Post-Romantic Aesthetics

Wordsworth's famous definition of poetry as 'emotion recollected in tranquility' (Preface to Lyrical Ballads, 1800) resonates with Saras's lyric practice. The geet tradition in Maithili — like the Romantic lyric in English — begins with personal emotional experience and transforms it through the reflective process of composition into something universally communicable. Coleridge's distinction between Fancy (mechanical combination of pre-existing elements) and Imagination (the living power that reshapes experience into new organic wholes) maps onto the critical difference between formulaic geet-writing and Saras's best work, which demonstrates the creative Imagination Coleridge valued.

Matthew Arnold's concept of the 'touchstone' — the quality passages from great literature that serve as standards for evaluation — has been much criticized but retains a practical critical utility. Arnold's insistence that literature must be 'a criticism of life' finds resonance in Saras's social-critical verse (Dhari Prashna Ee Uthaiye), where the lyric mode is put in the service of social interrogation.

## 5.3 New Criticism and Formalism: Empson, Brooks, Jakobson

The New Critics (I.A. Richards, William Empson, Cleanth Brooks, Robert Penn Warren) focused critical attention on the verbal texture of the literary work itself: its ambiguities, ironies, tensions, and internal coherences. Empson's Seven Types of Ambiguity (1930) provides a useful framework for analyzing Saras's ghazal practice, where — following the classical ghazal convention — every sher (couplet) must operate as a self-contained unit while also contributing to the poem's overall movement, creating what Empson would recognize as productive tensions between part and whole. Roman Jakobson's concept of the 'poetic function' — the orientation of language toward the message itself, through devices such as parallelism, rhyme, and rhythmic recurrence — is directly applicable to Saras's formal practice in both geet and ghazal.

## 5.4 Post-Structuralism and Derrida's Différance

Jacques Derrida's concept of différance — the perpetual deferral of fixed meaning through the play of differences within language — is illuminating for the ghazal form as practised by Saras. The ghazal's radif (refrain word/phrase) functions as a site of différance: the same word, repeated in every sher, accumulates different meanings as each new sher places it in a new semantic context. In Saras's ghazals, as in the classical tradition, the radif does not so much stabilize meaning as demonstrate its instability — each repetition reveals that what seemed like a fixed reference point is in fact continuously shifting.

## 5.5 Postcolonial Criticism: Spivak, Bhabha, Said

Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's question 'Can the subaltern speak?' acquires specific urgency in the context of Maithili literature, where — as the Videha Parallel History documents — the RTI investigation confirmed that the institutional machinery of cultural recognition has systematically excluded subaltern voices. Saras's position as a Maithili poet writing from Jharkhand — doubly marginalized, both as a speaker of a minority language and as a resident of a state perceived as peripheral to the Bihar-centred Maithili cultural geography — gives his writing a particular subaltern valence. Homi Bhabha's concept of the 'third space' — the in-between space where cultural identities are negotiated and hybridized — is applicable to Saras's creative position between the classical geet-ghazal tradition and the vernacular folk modernity of the Jharkhand Maithili diaspora. Edward Said's theory of Orientalism, adapted to the internal colonialism of the Indian cultural academy, illuminates the mechanisms by which the Sahitya Akademi's institutional power has constructed an 'official' Maithili tradition that othered and silenced writers like Saras.

## 5.6 Feminist Theory: Beauvoir, Butler, Spivak

Simone de Beauvoir's concept of woman as 'Other' — the one defined not in her own right but in relation to the male subject — is directly relevant to Dhari Prashna Ee Uthaiye, which (as its title 'She Asks This Question' announces) stages the moment when the subaltern woman subject claims the right to interrogate rather than be interrogated. Judith Butler's theory of performative gender — the idea that gender is not a fixed essence but a repeated performance that can be parodied, subverted, and rewritten — finds an echo in Saras's literary strategy of using the lyric form (traditionally associated with the male speaking subject) to voice feminine perspectives and questions.

# VI. Theoretical Framework III: Navya-Nyāya Epistemology as Literary Method

## 6.1 Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya and the Tattvacintāmaṇi

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (c. 1300–1350 CE), the founder of the Navya-Nyāya ('New Logic') school of Indian philosophy, composed his single masterwork, the Tattvacintāmaṇi ('Thought-Jewel of Valid Knowledge'), at Chadan village in the kingdom of Mithila. The Tattvacintāmaṇi is divided into four khaṇḍas (books): Pratyakṣa (Perception), Anumāna (Inference), Upamāna (Comparison/Analogy), and Śabda (Verbal Testimony). As Karl H. Potter notes in the Encyclopedia of Indian Philosophies (Vol. 6), the Navya-Nyāya innovation lay in shifting the school's focus from ontology (the 16 categories of classical Nyāya) to epistemology — the means by which valid knowledge is acquired, verified, and expressed.

Gaṅgeśa's central tool is the avacchedaka (literally 'limitor' or 'delimiter') — a logical operator that prevents ambiguity by specifying exactly which property or relation is being predicated of which subject. In traditional Indian logic, the statement 'The hill has fire' (parvato vahnimān) had always been subject to multiple interpretations. Gaṅgeśa's avacchedaka technique allowed a fully disambiguated proposition: not merely 'fire' but fire-delimited-by-smokeness, in the substrate hill-delimited-by-locus. Stephen Phillips and others have compared this to the type-theoretic precision of modern analytic philosophy (Frege, Russell), but it is more directly analogous to the precision demanded of any serious critical vocabulary.

## 6.2 Navya-Nyāya Applied to Literary Criticism

The application of Navya-Nyāya epistemology to literary criticism is not metaphorical but methodological. The four pramāṇas (sources of valid knowledge) Gaṅgeśa analyses — Pratyakṣa (direct perception), Anumāna (inference), Upamāna (analogy), and Śabda (verbal testimony) — correspond precisely to the four primary sources of literary knowledge:

Pratyakṣa (Direct Textual Reading): The critic's immediate engagement with the text — reading it carefully, experiencing its aesthetic effects, attending to its

formal features. This corresponds to what F.R. Leavis called 'the realization of the text in the reader'.

Anumāna (Inference): The critical conclusions drawn from textual evidence — generic identification, thematic analysis, intertextual connections. Just as Gaṅgeśa's Anumāna-khaṇḍa analyses the logical structure of inference (vyāpti — invariable concomitance between middle and major terms), critical inference must establish invariable connections between textual evidence and critical conclusions.

Upamāna (Comparison and Analogy): The comparative placing of a writer's work within tradition and against peers — what T.S. Eliot called 'tradition and the individual talent'. Gaṅgeśa defends Upamāna as an independent pramāṇa (against the Buddhist and Vaiśeṣika reductions of it to inference) because the specific kind of knowledge produced by perceived similarity cannot be reduced to inference.

Śabda (Verbal Testimony): The evidence of published criticism, editorial prefaces, author's statements, and historical documentation. Gaṅgeśa's analysis of Śabda pramāṇa — requiring ākāṅkṣā (syntactic completeness), yogyatā (semantic fitness), sannidhi (temporal proximity), and tātparya (speaker's intention) — provides a rigorous framework for evaluating the reliability of critical statements about a literary work.

The Navya-Nyāya requirement of avacchedaka precision — always specifying exactly what delimited entity is being discussed — serves as a corrective to the vagueness that afflicts much literary criticism. When we say Saras is 'lyrical', the Navya-Nyāya question is: lyrical in what respect, under which description, as compared to what standard? This precision is not pedantry but epistemological hygiene.

## 6.3 The Dooshan Panji and Epistemological Courage

The Videha Parallel History's recovery of the Dooshan Panji evidence about Gaṅgeśa — that he was born outside conventional legitimacy and married across caste lines — is itself an exercise in Navya-Nyāya epistemology. The Panji records are Śabda pramāṇa (verbal testimony); they qualify as valid testimony because they meet Gaṅgeśa's own criteria of tātparya (they were not composed to flatter or defame but as genealogical records), yogyatā (they are semantically consistent and internally coherent), and ākāṅkṣā (they form complete statements). The suppression of this testimony by Ramanath Jha constitutes what the Videha framework calls 'honour-killing of truth' — a

violation of Gaṅgeśa's own epistemological standards, an irony of the highest intellectual order. The Navya-Nyāya demand for pramāṇa-based knowledge — knowledge rigorously grounded in valid evidence — thus becomes, in the Videha framework, a democratic ethical demand: suppress no testimony, however inconvenient.

## VII. Critical Appreciation: Poetry and Lyrics (Aakhar Aakhar Geet Saras, 1999)

Aakhar Aakhar Geet Saras — published in 1999, when Maithili digital culture was still nascent and print was the primary medium of literary circulation — represents Saras's foundational statement as a lyric poet. The title itself is a program: 'Letter by Letter, Song of Saras' insists on the primacy of the written word (aakhar = letter/word) even in a literary tradition where the geet is primarily oral and performative.

The preface reveals a writer conscious of his place within a tradition and anxious to distinguish his contribution from mere imitation. The preface cites an impressive range of predecessors and contemporaries: Kavivar Sitaram Jha (the figure of the 'correct lineage' in Maithili ghazal and geet), Surendra Jha 'Suman', and the broader community of Maithili lyricists. This situating gesture is Upamāna pramāṇa in action: Saras defines himself through perceived similarity (to tradition) and perceived difference (his own innovation).

The thematic range of the collection — as recoverable from the table of contents — spans: devotional geet (songs to the gods, especially Shiva and the goddess), seasonal songs (monsoon, spring, harvest), love songs in the Vidyapati tradition of shringara, biraha songs of separation, and social-commentary pieces. This range corresponds exactly to the classical taxonomy of Maithili geet, suggesting that Saras is working self-consciously within and against tradition.

From the rasa-theory perspective, the dominant rasa is śṛṅgāra — but in its mature, complex form where erotic delight and separation longing exist in creative tension. Anandavardhana's dhvani is most visible in the biraha songs, where the literal narrative of the beloved's departure resonates with the collective biraha of the Maithili diaspora — the separation from Mithila itself, that 'golden window of light' that recurs in Saras's imagery across multiple collections.

From the Formalist perspective, Saras's geet display careful attention to the prosodic requirements of the genre: the mātrā (rhythmic unit) structure of Maithili geet follows specific patterns that are simultaneously aids to oral memorability and constraints within which the poet demonstrates skill. The New Critical principle that form and content are inseparable finds strong support in Saras's practice: the sonic textures of his geet — alliteration, internal rhyme, assonance — are not decorative but semantically active.

## VIII. Critical Appreciation: The Ghazal Tradition (Shonitayal Payark Nishan)

Shonitayal Payark Nishan ('Bloodstained Footprints') places Saras within the most technically demanding and historically richest genre in the Maithili literary repertoire: the ghazal. The Videha Parallel History (Part 4: 'The Revitalization of Maithili Ghazal: The Anchinhar Aakhar Movement') provides the essential historical context. The Maithili ghazal has a documented correct lineage from Pandit Jivan Jha (early 20th century) through Kavivar Sitaram Jha, Kashikant Mishra 'Madhup', Vijaynath Jha, and Yoganand Heera — followed by a 'dark interlude' in which grammatically incorrect ghazal writing erased the authentic practitioners from literary history. The Anchinhar Aakhar movement, launched on 11 April 2008, sought to restore formal standards through the Ghajalsastram.

The ghazal form's technical requirements are precise: the bahr (metre, derived from Arabic-Persian quantitative prosody), the qāfiyā (mono-rhyme at the end of every second misra), the radif (identical refrain), the matla (opening couplet in which both lines carry qāfiyā and radif), and the maqta (closing couplet, often containing the poet's takhallus or pen name). Saras's title 'Saras' appears as his takhallus in the maqta of his ghazals, following classical convention.

The title Shonitayal Payark Nishan evokes simultaneously the classical ghazal's vocabulary of wound and longing (the Udhri tradition of self-sacrificial love) and the modern tradition (Faiz Ahmed Faiz) in which this vocabulary becomes a transparent metaphor for political persecution and revolutionary hope. The word 'shonitayal' (bloodstained) places the collection squarely within the tradition of the ghazal as witness literature — poetry that testifies to suffering without sentimentalizing it.

From the Navya-Nyāya perspective, the ghazal's internal epistemology is instructive. Each sher must establish its own vyāpti (invariable concomitance) between the image-term (hetu) and the emotion or idea being demonstrated (sādhya). The best ghazal shers are those in which the logical connection between image and meaning is simultaneously inevitable and surprising — what T.S. Eliot would have called the 'objective correlative'. The Navya-Nyāya avacchedaka principle — specify exactly which property of which entity is being predicated — corresponds to the ghazal discipline of making every word carry its full semantic weight.

The radif (refrain) of a ghazal functions as what Derrida would call a 'trace' — a mark that seems to be a stable referent but reveals, through its repetition in different contexts, the fundamental instability of any fixed signification. Saras's ghazals, following the best practice of the tradition, use the radif not as decoration but as epistemological investigation: what does this word mean, really, across the full range of human experience?

## IX. Critical Appreciation: Social and Political Verse (Dhari Prashna Ee Uthaiye, 2015)

Dhari Prashna Ee Uthaiye ('She Asks This Question') is the most explicitly political of Saras's five collections. Published in 2015 under the Jharkhand Mithila Manch imprint, it represents a Maithili writer in the diaspora using the lyric form to interrogate not just personal experience but structural social conditions — particularly the condition of women in Maithili society.

The title's grammar is significant: Dhari is a feminine pronoun/noun ('she' or 'a woman'), and the verb Uthaiye ('raises') in the imperative-present form suggests both 'she raises' and 'let her raise' — a claim and an exhortation simultaneously. This grammatical ambiguity is itself a formal instance of dhvani: the literal meaning (she raises this question) resounds with the secondary suggestion (it is right that she should raise this question, and that the raising be heard).

From the perspective of feminist theory, this collection performs exactly the operation Judith Butler describes: it stages the speaking position of the woman as subject rather than object, performing — through the repeated act of poetic utterance — a gender identity that was denied by the social structures the poems

interrogate. Spivak's 'Can the subaltern speak?' finds an implicit answer: yes, through the poem, through the insistence on lyric presence.

The preface indicates that the collection is organized around specific social themes: marriage violence, land rights, migration and displacement, and the intersection of caste and gender. These are precisely the themes that the Videha Parallel History identifies as systematically excluded from the institutional Maithili literary canon. Saras's contribution to the parallel tradition is thus not merely aesthetic but archival: he documents experiences that would otherwise leave no literary trace.

From the perspective of Ramvilas Sharma's historical-materialist criticism, this collection is the most fully realized of Saras's five books: it demonstrates the connection between literary production and social conditions that Sharma argued was the ultimate measure of literary significance.

## X. Critical Appreciation: Children's Literature (Phool Titli Aa Tulbul, 2011)

Phool Titli Aa Tulbul ('Flowers, Butterflies, and the Babbling Brook') is a collection of children's songs in Maithili — a genre that has received very little sustained critical attention but whose cultural importance is immense, particularly for a minority language whose intergenerational transmission depends on the quality of its early-childhood literary culture.

From the perspective of aucitya (propriety, fittingness) — Kshemendra's criterion — Saras demonstrates exceptional skill. The songs are precisely calibrated for child perception: concrete, sensory, rhythmically repetitive, tonally warm. The songs are structured around the familiar Maithili child's world — flowers, butterflies, fish in the stream, the monsoon rain, the kitchen, the grandmother's stories — but organized with a poet's ear for sonic pleasure. The repetitive structures are not formulaic but purposeful: they create the memorability that allows children to internalize the Maithili language through pleasure rather than instruction.

The cultural-political significance of high-quality children's literature in Maithili is considerable. As the Videha framework documents, one of the key strategies of minority-language cultural maintenance is the production of attractive, enjoyable children's literature that makes the language desirable rather than merely obligatory. Saras's contribution to this project in Phool Titli

Aa Tulbul deserves to be recognized not only as literary achievement but as cultural activism.

From a Jakobsonian Formalist perspective, children's literature is the genre in which the 'poetic function' — the orientation of language toward itself, its sound and rhythm — is most nakedly primary. Saras's children's songs exploit the full range of phonetic resources available in Maithili: the retroflex consonants that have no equivalent in other Indo-Aryan languages, the distinctive vowel qualities, the characteristic morphological patterns — all become, in his songs, sources of sonic delight that subliminally teach the child to love the language's distinctive phonology.

## XI. Critical Appreciation: Prose Vision (Sonhula Ijotbala Khirki)

Sonhula Ijotbala Khirki ('The Golden Window of Light') is the most formally experimental of Saras's five books — a hybrid text that resists easy generic classification. There is a collection that oscillates between the lyric poem and the lyric prose piece, deploying an imagistic, reflective style that draws on the traditions of both the Maithili geet and the Hindi-Maithili prose poem.

The title's central image — the 'golden window of light' — is the kind of compressed symbolic image that the dhvani theory was developed to analyse. At the literal level, it is an architectural image: a window through which golden light enters. At the secondary (lakṣyārtha) level, it suggests the literary text itself as a 'window' — an aperture through which the reader gains access to a reality otherwise inaccessible. At the vyaṅgyārtha (suggested) level, the 'golden' quality and the 'light' together resonate with the classical equation of jnāna (knowledge) and jyoti (light), suggesting that the act of reading/writing is an act of illumination — both personal and social.

The Videha Parallel History's discussion of the 'Bīhani Kathā' (Seed Story) tradition in Maithili literature (Part 32) is relevant to Sonhula Ijotbala Khirki: the tradition of compact, imagistically dense short prose narratives that function simultaneously as story, meditation, and cultural memory. Saras's book appears to participate in this tradition, positioning itself within the democratic literary lineage that Videha has documented from the Charyapadas through Harimohan Jha to the contemporary moment.

# XII. Saras and the Maithili Ghazal Revival: The Anchinhar Aakhar Context

The Videha Parallel History (Part 4) documents the Anchinhar Aakhar movement's specific contribution to the Maithili ghazal: the creation of the Ghajalsastram (the first comprehensive Maithili theoretical account of the ghazal form) by Gajendra Thakur; the development of new Bahars (metres) specific to Maithili phonetics by Ashish Anchinhar; the expansion of the genre into Bal Ghazal (children's ghazal) and Bhakti Ghazal (devotional ghazal); and the digital democratization strategy that brought 350–400 new and previously marginalized writers into the ghazal tradition within a decade.

Saras's Shonitayal Payark Nishan must be situated within this specific historical moment. The question of whether Saras's ghazals meet the technical standards of the Anchinhar movement — bahr discipline, consistent qāfiyā, structurally correct matla and maqta — is both a formal critical question and a political one, since adherence to formal standards is itself, within the Anchinhar framework, a democratic act against the 'weak era' of grammatically incorrect ghazal writing that had erased legitimate practitioners from literary history.

Saras's takhallus 'Saras' in the maqta of his ghazals connects him directly to this tradition of formal self-inscription. The classical requirement that the poet name himself in the maqta is not vanity but epistemological accountability: the poet takes responsibility for the poem, stakes his identity on its truthfulness, and thereby makes the poem a form of valid testimony (Śabda pramāṇa) in Gaṅgeśa's sense.

The Maithili ghazal's journey from Arabic through Persian through Urdu into Maithili is documented in detail in the Videha Parallel History: from the pre-Islamic qasida, through the Sufi tradition (Rumi, Hafiz), through Amir Khusrau's vernacularization, through the golden age of Urdu ghazal (Mir, Ghalib, Faiz), and into the regional Indian language ghazal movements (Bengali: Nazrul Islam; Marathi: Suresh Bhat 'Ghazal Samrat'; Gujarati: Asim Randeri). Saras's ghazals participate in this hemispheric literary history while insisting on their specifically Maithili character.

## XIII. Comparative Analysis: Saras among Contemporary Maithili Poets

The Videha Parallel History identifies the three truly great contemporary voices of Maithili — all long ignored by the official Sahitya Akademi machinery until recently — as Jagdish Prasad Mandal (novelist; finally awarded Sahitya Akademi 2021 for Pangu), Rajdeo Mandal (described as the greatest living Maithili poet), and Bechan Thakur (greatest living Maithili dramatist). Saras occupies a different position in this geography: not in the highest tier of the official counter-canon, but as a productive, prolific, and formally accomplished lyricist whose contribution is to breadth rather than singular depth.

The comparison with Vijaynath Jha and Yoganand Heera — the ghazal practitioners who were erased from literary history during the 'dark interlude' and whose restoration the Anchinhar movement undertook — is instructive. Saras's work raises the same question: how much Maithili literary production has been lost because institutional mechanisms of recognition have failed to document and preserve it? The five books available in this study were preserved and made accessible through the Videha digital archive — without that archival intervention, their critical recovery would have been far more difficult.

Among his generation of Jharkhand-based Maithili writers, Saras stands out for the range and quantity of his output. Writers such as Dr Chandramani Jha (who appears in the colophon of Dhari Prashna Ee Uthaiye as a contact person for the Jharkhand Mithila Manch), Dr Jai Prakash Chaudhary 'Janak', and Kumar Manish Arvind represent his immediate literary community — a diaspora literary culture that has maintained the Maithili tradition in an industrial context (Bokaro Steel City, Ranchi) very different from the agrarian Mithila heartland.

## XIV. Language, Idiom, and Prosody

Saras writes in contemporary colloquial Maithili — the variety spoken in the Mithila heartland (Darbhanga-Madhubani region) and its diaspora communities, as distinct from the Nepali-border variety of Maithili or the heavily Sanskritized literary Maithili of older generations. This linguistic choice is itself a political act: it privileges accessibility over erudition, democratic intelligibility over scholarly exclusivity.

The characteristic features of Saras's Maithili idiom. He uses the second-person intimate pronoun tumi and the corresponding verb forms consistently — the intimate address that in classical Maithili geet traditionally figured the beloved but in Saras's social-critical verse figures the oppressed person who is being addressed in solidarity. He deploys compound verbs and idiomatic expressions that give his language a strongly oral character — sentences that feel spoken rather than written, a quality crucial for both the geet (which is sung) and the ghazal (which is recited at mushairas).

In prosodic terms, Saras's geet follow the mātrā-based system of Maithili lyric prosody — a system that differs from Sanskrit quantitative metres but shares with them the principle of rhythmic regularity as a criterion of formal excellence. His ghazals follow the Perso-Arabic bahr system, adapted to Maithili phonology by the Anchinhar movement's theoretical work. The children's songs in Phool Titli Aa Tulbul use the simplest prosodic structures — short lines, strong end-rhyme, rhythmic predictability — that are optimal for children's oral acquisition.

The Devanāgarī script in which all five books are written (rather than the traditional Tirhuta/Mithilākṣara script) reflects the practical reality of contemporary Maithili publishing: Devanāgarī has wider readership among the diaspora. The Videha movement's work on Tirhuta Unicode and its archival of 11,000 palm-leaf Tirhuta manuscripts stands as a parallel recovery of the indigenous script tradition that Saras's books, for practical reasons, do not employ.

## XV. Conclusion

Siyaram Jha 'Saras' emerges from this study as a significant figure in the democratic strand of contemporary Maithili literature: prolific, formally skilled, emotionally honest, and politically aware. His five published collections represent a substantial literary achievement across four distinct genres — lyric poetry, ghazal, social-critical verse, and children's literature — and his career in the Maithili diaspora of Jharkhand exemplifies the creative vitality of minority-language cultures in conditions of displacement.

Assessed through the rasa-dhvani framework of Indian criticism, his best work achieves genuine aesthetic effect: the śṛṅgāra vipralambha of his geet resonates with the collective biraha of the Maithili diaspora; the dhvani of his title-images

operates at multiple levels of meaning; his children's songs demonstrate exemplary aucitya. Through the Western critical frameworks — New Criticism, Formalism, postcolonial theory, feminist theory — his work reveals its engagement with both formal tradition and social challenge. Through the Navya-Nyāya lens of Gaṅgeśa, his ghazals demonstrate the epistemological discipline that the form demands: each sher a valid inference, the radif a site of precision under pressure.

The Videha Parallel History Framework's most important contribution to a critical study of Saras is structural: it reminds us that the conditions of literary recognition are as important as the literary achievement itself, and that the silence of institutional criticism about a writer is not evidence of that writer's unimportance but evidence of institutional failure. Saras deserves — and this study attempts to provide — the kind of careful, theoretically grounded, documentarily thorough critical attention that the Sahitya Akademi's machinery has too often withheld from writers of the democratic Maithili tradition.

The recovery of Gaṅgeśa's full human story — the philosopher born outside legitimacy, married across caste, who nevertheless produced the intellectual achievement that made Mithila the capital of Indian logic — is a fitting symbol for this critical project. Saras's career too demonstrates that the most significant literary achievements in Maithili's parallel tradition have often come from writers working outside, or at the margins of, institutional recognition. The Tattvacintāmaṇi's demand for pramāṇa-based knowledge — know on the basis of valid evidence, suppress no testimony, specify your claims with avacchedaka precision — is both a philosophical and an ethical demand: see clearly, speak honestly, and do not honour-kill the truth.

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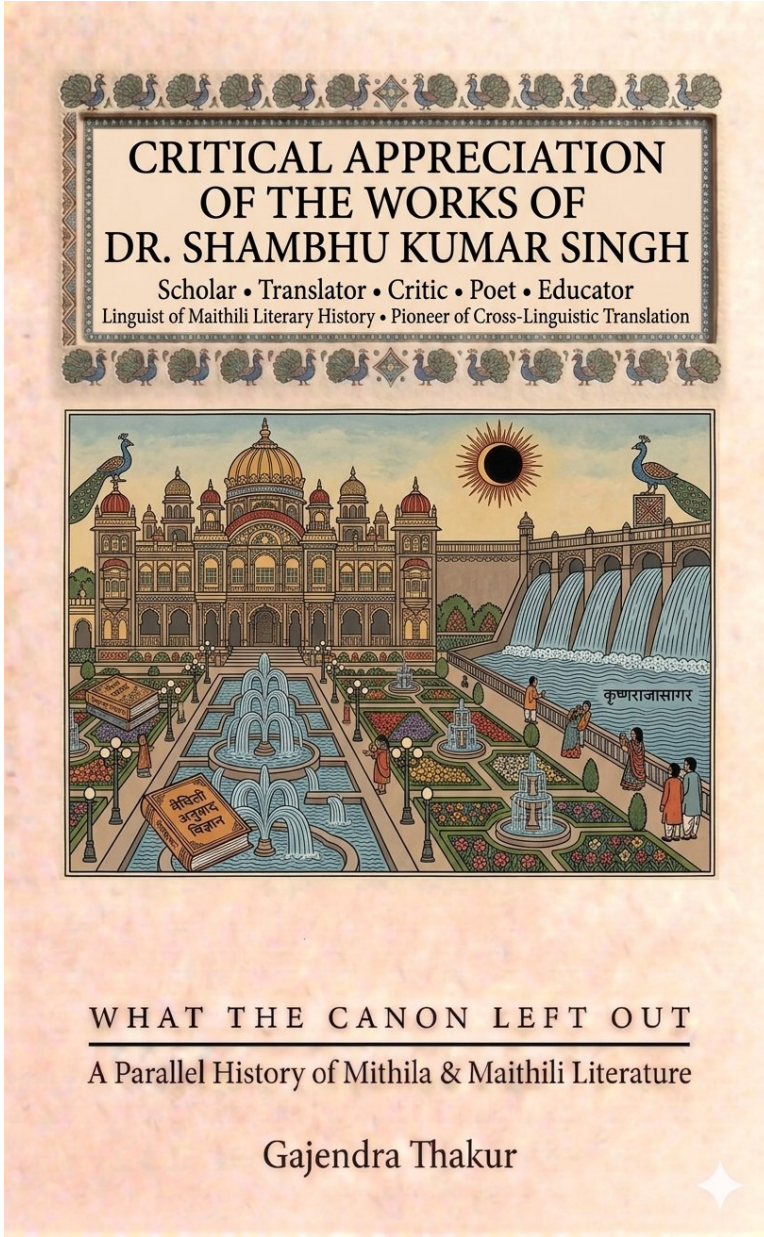
**LESSON 079 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**



# CRITICAL APPRECIATION OF THE WORKS OF

**DR. SHAMBHU KUMAR SINGH**

*Scholar • Translator • Critic • Poet • Educator*

*Linguist of Maithili Literary History • Pioneer of Cross-Linguistic Translation*

*Analysed through Indian & Western Literary Theory*

*Videha Parallel History Framework • Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa*

## I. BIOGRAPHICAL AND PROFESSIONAL OVERVIEW

Dr. Shambhu Kumar Singh (Devanagari: डॉ. शम्भु कुमार सिंह) was born on 18 April 1965 in the village of Lahuaar, Mahishi Block, Saharsa District, Bihar — a locale embedded in the cultural heartland of Mithila. His father is Shri Chaturbhuj Singh and his mother Shrimati Jaymala Devi. His early education was in the village itself, and he subsequently pursued higher studies at Tilka Manjhi Bhagalpur University, Bhagalpur, Bihar, from which he obtained the B.A. (with Honours in Maithili), M.A. in Maithili (with Gold Medal), and the Ph.D. degree in 2008. His doctoral thesis, completed under the supervision of scholars at Tilka Manjhi Bhagalpur University, bears the title ‘Maithili Naatakak Samajik Vivarttan’ (‘The Social Transformation of Maithili Drama’) — a comprehensive study in Maithili that analyses the trajectory of modern Maithili theatre as a mirror of the social changes in Mithila from the colonial period to the present.

He qualified the Bihar Eligibility Test (BET, equivalent to the national NET examination) for lecturers in 1995. Following a period when, as he himself writes with characteristic honesty, ‘the pen became estranged from him,’ Dr. Singh’s creative and intellectual life was reconstituted when he joined the National Translation Mission (NTM), Central Institute of Indian Languages (CIIL), Mysore, in 2008, where he served as Educational Consultant (Maithili).

The NTM, established on 1 July 2008 under the directorship of the eminent linguist-poet Prof. Uday Narayana Singh ‘Nachiḅeta’, had as its central mission the translation of high-level knowledge textbooks from English into all eighteen scheduled languages of India. Dr. Singh was one of the Maithili team’s pivotal figures, representing the mission at translation-orientation workshops and facilitating the production of knowledge materials in Maithili.

His literary output spans multiple registers and genres: scholarly critical essays on Maithili literary history and periodisation, research articles on modern Maithili drama and its social dimensions, original Maithili poetry, and — most significantly for the Videha digital archive — the Maithili translation of the celebrated Konkani novel ‘Pakhalo’ (orig. by Tukaram Rama Shet, 1980-81 Goa Kala Akademi award winner), serialised in Videha eJournal from 15 July 2009 and later collected in Videha: Sadeha 26 (published with companion work by Dr. Arun Kumar Singh). His writings have appeared in numerous prestigious Maithili journals and periodicals over the years. His poem-tribute to the late Prof. Anima Singh, published in Videha 365 (2025) under the title ‘Smriti Shesh: Snehil Aasheervacan’ (‘Surviving in Memory: An Affectionate Blessing’), is among his most personally revealing prose-poem pieces, combining memoir, intellectual history, and lyric elegy.

The biographical fact that Dr. Singh is from Saharsa district, and that the celebrated Maithili writer Anima Singh — whose family was also from Saharsa — greeted him with the warm kinship of native soil (‘ahaan hamra sasurk lok chhi, hamra jilak lok chhi, Mithilak lok chhi’) encodes a crucial dimension of his social and cultural positioning: his identity within Mithila is not primarily that of the Maithil Brahman or Kayastha elite but of the broader Mithila society whose claims to the literary heritage have been partially suppressed by the canonising institutions.

## II. THE VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY FRAMEWORK: SITUATING DR. SHAMBHU KUMAR SINGH

The Videha Parallel History of Mithila and Maithili Literature, founded and edited by Gajendra Thakur and published through Videha (ISSN 2229-547X), proceeds from the thesis that the received canon of Maithili literature has been systematically constructed to privilege certain social groups, genres, and

institutions, while marginalising subaltern, Dalit, diaspora, OBC, and non-‘standard’ voices. The framework insists that a full and democratic account of Maithili literature must recover and critically evaluate the work of those excluded from the Sahitya Akademi-centred mainstream.

Dr. Shambhu Kumar Singh occupies a distinctive position within this framework. He is first and foremost a scholar-critic rather than a purely creative writer — a figure whose primary contribution is the systematic intellectual labour of documenting, analysing, and interpreting Maithili literary history for multiple audiences. His essay on Maithili literary periodisation (Videha: Sadeha 26), designed explicitly for UPSC civil service examination candidates, is a striking instance of the democratising impulse: the recovery of complex literary-historical knowledge from the specialised circuit of academic Maithili scholarship and its transmission to the widest possible readership, including aspirant civil servants who need a functional understanding of Maithili literary history for competitive examinations.

His translation of ‘Pakhalo’ from Konkani into Maithili (via an intermediate Hindi rendition with colleague Sebi Fernandes) is equally paradigmatic of the Videha framework’s values: it breaks the habitual insularity of Maithili literary culture by introducing a literary work from the Konkani tradition — a language and people utterly distant from Mithila in geography, culture, and social formation — into the Maithili literary world. This act of inter-linguistic hospitality is, within the Videha Parallel History’s terms, a model of what the democratic, inclusive, multi-vocal Maithili literary tradition ought to look like.

His doctoral research on Maithili drama and social transformation is directly aligned with the Videha framework’s interest in literature as a social document. The essays published in Videha: Sadeha 26 — on poverty in modern Maithili drama, on the woman question in Maithili theatre, on child marriage, dowry, and sexual violence as depicted on the Maithili stage — constitute a systematic sociology of Maithili literary production that aligns with the framework’s commitment to subaltern and feminist critical perspectives.

# III. THE SCHOLARLY OEUVRE: CRITICAL ANALYSIS

## A. Maithili Sahityak Kaal-Nirdharan (Periodisation of Maithili Literature)

This essay, published in Videha: Sadeha 26 and subtitled ‘Useful for UPSC Examinees’, is a sustained exercise in what the Indian critical tradition would call sahitya-itihas (literary history) combined with the philosophical analysis of kaal-vibhaajan (temporal periodisation). Dr. Singh begins from the foundational proposition that literature is ‘the accumulated repository of knowledge’ (‘gyaan raashik sanchit kosh’), and that periodisation is necessary for systematic study, while acknowledging that the literary stream is intrinsically continuous and not susceptible to sharp demarcation.

The essay surveys thirteen major scholarly positions on the periodisation of Maithili literature, from M.M. Dr. Umesh Mishra’s tripartite division (Aadikaal 1100-1300; Madhyakaal 1300-1800; Aadhunik Kaal 1800 to present) through Dr. Jayakant Mishra’s four-part scheme in his Sahitya Akademi history, Kumar Gangnanand Singh’s alternative division, Dr. Subhadra Jha’s linguistic-developmental scheme, Dr. Ramanath Jha’s bipartite division (Vidyapati yug and Chanda Jha yug), Dr. Durganaath Jha ‘Shreesh’’s elaborated scheme, Dr. Shailendra Mohan Jha’s revisions, Dr. Radha Krishna Chaudhary’s survey, and several others.

Dr. Singh’s critical engagement with these positions is not merely descriptive but analytically independent. He consistently identifies the logical lacunae in each position: Umesh Mishra’s 1950 CE terminus for the modern period is identified as historically unmotivated; Jayakant Mishra’s 1300 CE starting point is challenged on the grounds that it excludes substantial pre-Vidyapati Maithili material (including the Charyapada); the reliance on political events (the Oinwar dynasty’s fall, the Court of Wards arrangement in Darbhanga) as markers of literary periodisation is interrogated. His own synthesis proposes a three-part division: the Giti-Kaavya Yug (lyric poetry age), the Naatak Yug (drama age), and the Gadya Yug (prose age), which in spiritual-aesthetic terms correspond to Shringaar Yug, Bhakti Yug, and Aadhunik Yug respectively.

From the perspective of Navya-Nyaya epistemology, this essay demonstrates a sophisticated use of anumana (inference) and tarka (critical reasoning). Each previous scholar’s position is treated as a paksha (proposition) whose sadhya (the property it claims to establish: a valid scheme of Maithili literary history) is

subjected to scrutiny of its hetu (reasons offered). The recurring identification of upAdhi (limiting conditions that invalidate the inference) — such as Jayakant Mishra's neglect of pre-1300 CE material — constitutes a classically Navya-Nyaya move: showing that the vyapti (universal concomitance between the reason and the conclusion) does not hold without qualification. Dr. Singh's own synthesis claims to remove these upAdhis by proposing a literary-aesthetic rather than political-historical basis for periodisation.

In western literary-historical terms, the essay's method is closest to the tradition of literary historiography theorised by René Wellek and Austin Warren ('Theory of Literature', 1948), who insist that literary history must be grounded in the immanent development of literary forms and conventions rather than in external political or social chronology. Dr. Singh's critique of schemes that rely on the Oinwar dynasty's fall or the Darbhanga Court of Wards as periodising markers anticipates precisely this Wellekian argument.

## B. Aadhhunik Maithili Naatakme Chitrit: Nirdhanataak Samasya (The Problem of Poverty in Modern Maithili Drama)

This research essay, drawn from Dr. Singh's doctoral thesis and published in Videha: Sadeha 26, deploys the methodology of social criticism within the framework of Maithili dramatic literature. It surveys the representation of poverty (nirdhanataa) in a systematic corpus of post-independence Maithili plays: Jeevanath Jha's 'Veer-Virendra' (1956), Bhagya Narayana Jha's 'Manorath' (1966), Babusaheb Chaudhary's 'Kuhes' (1967), Gunnath Jha's 'Kaniya-Putra' (1967), Mahendra Malangiya's 'Okra Aanganakaa Barhamasa' (1980), Nachiketa's 'Naayakak Naam Jeevan' (1971), Arvind Kumar 'Akku's 'Aagi Dhadaki Rahal Chhai' (1981), Govind Jha's 'Antim Pranaam' (1982), Gangesh Gunjan's 'Budhibadhia' (1982), among others.

The essay's analytical framework is socio-literary: it traces the representation of the poor — the landless labourer, the migrant worker, the hungry child, the family without shelter — through close readings of dialogue and situation in these plays. The critical method is comparative and contextual: the plays are not treated in isolation but as documents of a shared social reality, and their formal devices (the lament, the ironic juxtaposition, the dramatic monologue of the poor person) are analysed in relation to their social referents.

The rasa theory application here is one of sustained Karuna-rasa (sorrow): the essay identifies the dominant emotional register of the poverty-drama corpus as the elicitation of compassion and grief in the audience, combined with what Bharatamuni's Natyashastra calls Raudra (righteous fury) at the conditions

producing poverty. The essay quotes directly from the plays, and these quotations function as what Anandavardhana would call vyangya (suggestive resonance) — the bare, unadorned dialogue of the poor (‘Annabin pet jaritai, bastar bina thithurbai ke keli aa ghar ta dekhaite chhi’ — ‘Without food the belly burns, without clothes we shiver, and as for a home, you can see it yourselves’) achieves its literary force through the defamiliarising exposure of social conditions normally invisible in the dominant literary tradition.

From a Marxist-materialist perspective, the essay situates Maithili drama within the structural contradictions of Bihar’s agrarian economy: the landless labourer’s dependence on the monsoon, the contractor’s exploitation of migrant workers, the failure of state welfare to reach the poor. Georg Lukacs’ concept of ‘typicality’ (‘Studies in European Realism’, 1950) is relevant here: the poverty figures in these plays are not random individuals but typical representatives of a social class, whose individual suffering enacts the systemic conditions of agrarian under-development. Dr. Singh’s essays achieve Lukacsian realism not by their own formal innovation but by identifying and celebrating the realist achievement of the plays he analyses.

## C. Maithili Samajik Naatakak Mul Kendra Bindu: Naari Samasya (The Woman Question as the Core of Maithili Social Drama)

This companion essay surveys the representation of women’s oppression in modern Maithili social drama, covering the domains of physical torture (shaareerik prataadanaa), sexual exploitation (yaun utpeedan), child marriage (baal vivah), and dowry (dahej). The essay opens with a synoptic history of the position of women in Indian and specifically Mithilanchal society from the Vedic period to the present, tracing the paradox that a society which produces the famous maxim ‘Yatra Naaaryastu Poojyante Ramante Tatra Devataah’ (where women are worshipped, there the gods rejoice) simultaneously subjects women to sustained and systematic oppression.

The essay then moves through a sequence of dramatic texts, quoting from each to illustrate its chosen theme. The methodology is rigorously textual: Dr. Singh does not generalise about women’s oppression in the abstract but grounds each claim in specific dialogue and plot. The physical abuse of Sugiya in Govind Jha’s ‘Basaat’, the sexual exploitation of Nilam in Tripti Narayana Lal’s ‘Sappat’, the terrible consequences of child marriage in ‘Triveni’, and the devastating psychological effects of dowry demand in Sudhanshu Shekhar Chaudhary’s ‘Letaait Aachar’ are each given detailed citation and commentary.

The essay's most theoretically sophisticated moment is its analysis of the play 'Karn' by Kanchinath Jha 'Kiran', in which the author uses the mythological figures of Surya and Kunti to allegorise the sexual exploitation of lower-caste women by upper-caste men. Dr. Singh identifies this as 'laakshanik roop' (allegorical/figurative form) — a category that aligns precisely with what Indian criticism calls aropita-lakshana (imposed signification), wherein a mythological vehicle carries a contemporary social tenor. In Anandavardhana's terms, this is vivartana dhvani (transformative suggestion): the stated meaning (the Mahabharat myth) is replaced by a more powerful unstated meaning (contemporary caste-sexual oppression). The play's dialogue — in which Surya (the upper-caste male) articulates his logic of exploitation with chilling clarity — is cited at length and shown to encode a critique of the entire patriarchal-caste system.

From a feminist theoretical perspective, the essay engages with what Adrienne Rich calls 'the politics of location': the specific, bodily, historically embedded experience of Maithili women's oppression is not reducible to a general feminist or humanist account. The essay's consistent return to the specific social conditions of Mithila — the taamasik pati (oppressive husband), the saas-sasur (in-laws), the baal-vaivya (child widowhood) — insists on the situatedness of the theoretical claim. This is consistent with Sara Ruddick's feminist epistemology ('Maternal Thinking', 1989), which foregrounds the particular, embodied, relational knowledge produced by women's actual social experience.

The essay also engages with the broader question of what literature can do in social terms. By documenting that Maithili dramatists from the 1950s onward have consistently addressed women's oppression, the essay implicitly claims for Maithili drama a socially progressive tradition that has been underrecognised. This claim is consistent with the Videha Parallel History Framework's broader project of recovering the democratic, socially critical tradition within Maithili literature.

## D. Smriti Shesh: Snehil Aasheervacan (Surviving in Memory: An Affectionate Blessing)

Published in Videha 365 (Issue 365, the 2025 commemorative volume), this prose-lyric memoir is one of Dr. Singh's most artistically accomplished pieces. It narrates his chance visit to the legendary Maithili scholar and writer Prof. Anima Singh (1926-2016, wife of Prof. Prabodhnarayan Singh) at her flat in Lake Garden, Kolkata, in July 2009, en route from Saharsa to Mysore. The visit

is framed by the opening discovery, in 2016, of the newspaper obituary announcing Prof. Anima Singh's death — and the resurgence of her remembered blessing ('Jeebu! Khub tarakki karu!' — 'Live! May you achieve great things!').

The narrative is built around a series of vivid sensory details: the dusty, half-renovated flat; the luminous figure of Prof. Anima Singh in her striped saree with food-stained hands; her torrent of questions about Maithili life in Mysore, about the health of Prof. Uday Narayana Singh 'Nachiketa', about the number of Maithili workers at CIIL; and the quietly comic episode of the packet of ground moong lentils that Dr. Singh's mother had given him for the journey, which he eventually offers to Prof. Anima Singh, who lifts it to her nose, inhales, and exclaims at the fragrance of dal ground at home on a stone grinder ('khaapdi me bhujalaa jantme darardal mung dal').

In terms of rasa, this piece achieves what Abhinavagupta would classify as Shant-rasa tinged with Karuna: the memory of the visit is suffused with a quietness of spiritual recognition — a great literary figure's warmth toward a young scholar from her region, a fragrance that triggers the memory of a lost home-world — and the knowledge of her subsequent death transforms the memory into elegy. The piece's structural principle is the chiasmus: it opens with the 2016 obituary, moves back to the 2009 visit, and returns to the 2016 obituary, so that the remembered blessing ('live and flourish') frames both the life of the remembered person and the continued life of the rememberer. This is vakrokti (oblique expression) in Kuntaka's sense: the piece's meaning is not its surface narrative but its enacted meditation on literary transmission, the gift of language, and the persistence of memory as a form of cultural continuity.

The detail of the moong dal is the piece's symbolic centre. The dal — ground on the stone grinder, fragrant with the memory of village life — represents exactly what Prof. Anima Singh says she misses: the maati-paani (soil and water) of Mithila, the sensory textures of a world that urban and academic life has distanced her from. That a young scholar from Saharsa carries this fragrance in his bag, and offers it to the great writer, is a moment of cultural transmission — the younger generation carrying the older generation's lost world back to it. The inversion of the usual guru-shishya (teacher-student) direction — normally the elder gives the younger — is a quiet structural irony that the piece's form enacts without stating.

## E. The Poetry: Ateet, Aas, Lori, Baaju Sainik, Priyvaar Sampadakji

Dr. Singh's Maithili poetry, published in Videha: Sadeha 26, ranges across three distinct registers: the philosophical-meditative ('Ateet' — 'The Past'; 'Aas' — 'Hope'), the lyric-social ('Lori' — 'Lullaby'), the patriotic-empathetic ('Baaju Sainik! Kon Thaam?' — 'Speak, Soldier! Where Are You?'), and the epistolary-celebratory ('Priyvaar Sampadakji' — 'Dear Editor').

'Ateet' is a meditative lyric on the relationship between past, present, and future. Its formal structure is a series of balanced propositions: the past was witness to its time; what it took from us is memory (smriti); what it gave us is condition (sthiti); from the churning of memory and condition, the future can become good. This triadic movement — past-present-future — enacts the Navya-Nyaya epistemological structure of anumana (inference): from known premises (the past as experiential substrate), through the mediation of present cognition, to the conclusion about the future. The poem's Rasa is Shant (tranquillity), the ninth rasa recognised by Abhinavagupta, arising from a non-attached, contemplative stance toward temporal experience.

'Aas' (Hope) sustains the meditative mode but inflects it with Vira-rasa (heroic aspiration): 'Chhee ekhan tama me, samay vishama me, jhanjhavaat bhral achhi hamaraa jeevan me' ('I am in darkness now, in difficult times, my life filled with storm') — yet the poem's resolution is affirmative: hope for a truthful, free, karma-fulfilling future. The poem's rhetoric is that of the svalpa-loka (the compressed world-view), compressing vast temporal and existential experience into few syllables.

'Lori' (Lullaby) is the collection's most socially complex poem. Its surface form is a traditional lullaby address ('Tu lori gaa hum suti jaayeb / Maaye lori gaa hum suti jaayeb' — 'Sing me a lullaby, I shall sleep, Mother, sing me a lullaby'), but its content violates the genre's conventional comfort: the child speaker is hungry, cold, homeless, watching a white dog in a car eating food while the human child starves ('Okra gaadime / ujraa kukur achhi ghoomi rahal / khaa doodh-bhaat / ee pashu jaati' — 'In a car / a white dog is riding about / eating milk and rice / this animal class'). The inversion — the animal fed while the human child starves — is a device of vakrokti whose satiric force is intensified by the lullaby frame. In Bakhtin's terms, the poem is a carnivalesque inversion of the social hierarchy: the dog (symbol of the wealthy's petted comfort) is placed above the human child (symbol of the poor's destitution).

‘Baaju Sainik! Kon Thaam?’ (Speak, Soldier! Where Are You?) is a long patriotic-empathetic poem addressed to the Indian soldier, who is imagined at different postings — Siachen, the Line of Control, Rajouri and Doda in Jammu, Kargil, the sea coasts at Kochi, Goa, Visakhapatnam and Andaman, the desert at Jaisalmer. The poem’s speaker is a woman who knits a sweater for the soldier and wants to send it, but does not know his name or posting (‘Sneh-bhral sanes pathaabi / ahankanak naam’ — ‘I shall send a love-message to your name’). The poem’s refrains (‘Baaju sainik! Kon thaam? / Sneh-bhral sanes pathaabi / ahankanak naam’ — ‘Speak, Soldier! Where are you? / I shall send a message of love / to your name’) create the effect of a dhrupad (fixed refrain in classical music), whose repetition deepens the emotional resonance. The Rasa here is Vira (heroism, in the civic-empathetic sense), combined with Shringaar-Vatsalya (affectionate love for the nation’s protector).

‘Priyvaar Sampadakji’ is an apostrophe addressed to the editor of Videha, Gajendra Thakur. It is among the most self-referential poems in Dr. Singh’s oeuvre: it celebrates the editor’s intellectual and cultural work in a series of participial phrases, each beginning with a continuous-aspect verb that enacts sustained, ongoing action. The poem’s cumulative structure enacts the sense of unceasing productive labour: ‘satsya se bhent karaith rahi’ (meeting with truth continuously), ‘garel murdaakem ukharaith rahi’ (uprooting the buried corpse of old falsehoods), ‘nava-nava itihaas banaabait rahi’ (building ever-new histories), ‘Mithila, Maithili evam Maithilkem paribhashit karaith rahi’ (defining Mithila, Maithili, and the Maithil people). This poem is a meta-text within the Videha Parallel History series: it enacts the values of the framework from within the creative practice, naming and honouring the editorial labour that makes the framework possible.

## F. Pakhalo: The Konkani Novel in Maithili Translation

The translation of Tukaram Rama Shet’s Goa Kala Akademi-awarded Konkani novel ‘Pakhalo’ into Maithili represents Dr. Singh’s most substantial creative-intellectual achievement. The project was begun in 2009, with an intermediate step through Hindi (the Konkani original was rendered into Hindi by Sebi Fernandes, Dr. Singh’s colleague at CIIL Mysore, before Dr. Singh performed the Hindi-to-Maithili transposition), and was serialised in Videha eJournal from 15 July 2009 onward before being collected in Videha: Sadeha 26.

The title ‘Pakhalo’ means ‘wings’ in Konkani — an image of aspiration, liberation, and the desire to transcend constraint. The original novel is set in the Goan Catholic community and engages with themes of social mobility, cultural

memory, and the tensions between tradition and modernity — themes that resonate deeply with the social conditions of Mithila. Dr. Singh's translation preface ('Anuvaadakak Disas') is a model of translatorial honesty: he acknowledges the indirect route of the translation (Konkani to Hindi, Hindi to Maithili), credits Sebi Fernandes, expresses gratitude to the original author for permission and to Gajendra Thakur for publication, and explicitly positions himself as a 'student' rather than a 'scholar' or 'translator' — an act of intellectual humility that is simultaneously a statement of method.

The translation raises significant theoretical questions about the nature and ethics of translatorial practice. In Maithili literary culture, translation from other Indian languages has been relatively uncommon; the bulk of translation has been into or from Hindi and English. Dr. Singh's choice to translate from Konkani — a relatively small language with a small literary tradition, whose principal community (the Goan Catholics) is culturally remote from Mithila's Hindu-Brahmin social world — is an act of deliberate cross-cultural reaching that the Videha framework explicitly values.

From the perspective of translation theory, the project can be analysed using Lawrence Venuti's framework ('The Translator's Invisibility', 1995): the choice between 'domestication' (translating into the target culture's idiom) and 'foreignization' (preserving the source culture's strangeness) is intrinsic to every translation project. Dr. Singh's route through Hindi may predispose his Maithili version toward partial domestication (since the Hindi intermediary inevitably filters some of the Konkani source's cultural specificity), but his explicit acknowledgement of this limitation, and his preservation of Konkani cultural references within the Maithili text, suggest an attempt at what Venuti calls 'resistant translation' — a refusal to fully assimilate the other into the familiar.

In Susan Bassnett's terms ('Translation Studies', 1980), translation is a form of cultural exchange that, at its best, enriches the receiving culture by bringing it into contact with otherwise inaccessible worldviews. The introduction of Goan Catholic social life into the Maithili literary world through 'Pakhalo' is precisely this kind of enrichment. That it was possible at all — and that it was first published not in print but in a digital journal accessible globally — is itself a fact with significance for the sociology of Maithili literature.

# IV. NAVYA-NYĀYA EPISTEMOLOGICAL ANALYSIS

## A. Gaṅgeśa's Framework and Dr. Singh's Scholarly Method

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (c. 1320 CE), the founding figure of Navya-Nyaya and author of the Tattvacintāmaṇi, developed the most rigorous epistemological framework in the history of Indian philosophy. His insistence on the precise analysis of the structure of cognition — distinguishing prama (valid cognition) from aprama (invalid cognition), and specifying the exact conditions under which anumana (inference), pratyaksha (perception), and shabda (testimony) yield valid knowledge — provides a powerful set of analytical tools for literary criticism.

The relevance of Navya-Nyaya to Dr. Singh's scholarly work is direct. His essay on literary periodisation is, at its core, a sustained exercise in what Navya-Nyaya calls tarka-vidhi (the method of critical examination): each previous scholar's periodisation scheme is treated as a vyapti-claim (a claim about universal concomitance between a set of literary-historical markers and a set of literary periods), and each such claim is subjected to examination for upAdhi (limiting conditions that invalidate the vyapti). The systematic identification and removal of upAdhis in previous schemes constitutes the logical core of Dr. Singh's argument for his own three-period scheme.

Gaṅgeśa's analysis of paroksha-prama (mediate valid cognition, knowledge acquired through testimony and inference rather than direct perception) is also directly relevant to Dr. Singh's translatorial practice. The translation of 'Pakhalo' — which proceeds through the mediation of Hindi — is epistemologically a case of paroksha-prama: the Maithili reader's access to the Konkani original is mediated through two layers of linguistic transformation, and the validity of the resulting cognition depends on the reliability of each mediating step. Dr. Singh's transparent acknowledgement of this mediation in his preface is a Navya-Nyaya-consistent act: it specifies the pramana (source of cognition) and its conditions of reliability, allowing the reader to calibrate their epistemic trust accordingly.

The Tattvacintāmaṇi's concept of visheshana-visheshya-sambandha (the relationship between qualifier and the qualified) is applicable to Dr. Singh's critical practice of close textual quotation. In his drama essays, each quoted passage functions as a visheshana (qualifier) that grounds and specifies the visheshya (the general critical claim about social conditions in Maithili drama).

The relationship between the quoted text and the critical claim is not merely illustrative but constitutive: the text is the evidence without which the claim would be a bare generalisation (samanya-jnana) rather than a specific, verified cognition (vishesha-jnana).

### B. The Epistemology of Literary Translation

The question of how a translated text yields valid knowledge of the original is a question with deep roots in both the Navya-Nyaya and the Western hermeneutic traditions. In Navya-Nyaya terms, the translated text is a case of paraprakasha (illumination by another) — the target-language reader's understanding of the source text is mediated by the translator's apta (reliable testimony). The validity of this testimony depends on the translator's aptata: their competence in both source and target languages, their cultural understanding, and their fidelity to the original's meaning.

Dr. Singh's 'Pakhalo' translation acknowledges its own limitations of aptata with remarkable frankness. The indirection through Hindi is not concealed but foregrounded; the translator's debt to Sebi Fernandes is not minimised but honoured. In Navya-Nyaya terms, this constitutes what might be called a 'certified testimony': the translator has specified the conditions of his knowledge, identified the mediating steps, and named the co-witnesses. This epistemological transparency is itself a form of scholarly integrity.

## V. RASA, DHVANI, VAKROKTI: INDIAN LITERARY THEORY

### A. Rasa Analysis

Dr. Singh's creative and critical output engages all nine rasas of Bharatamuni's and Abhinavagupta's system. The dominant rasas in his creative work are Shant (tranquillity: 'Ateet', 'Aas'), Karuna (sorrow and compassion: 'Lori', the poverty-drama essays, the memoir of Prof. Anima Singh), and Vira (heroism: 'Baaju Sainik'). The dominant rasa in his critical work is what the tradition might call Jugupsaa-transformed-into-Vira: the scholarly recording of social pathology (poverty, child marriage, sexual exploitation) with a reformist energy that transforms the initial disgust into a call to action.

Abhinavagupta's theory of the sahridaya (the sensitive reader who participates in the text's emotional world) is directly relevant to the pedagogical dimension of Dr. Singh's essays on Maithili drama. These essays are explicitly addressed to UPSC candidates — a readership that is not necessarily familiar with the Maithili dramatic tradition — and their rhetorical strategy is precisely that of cultivating sahridayataa in an uninitiated audience: by providing extensive quotation and contextual commentary, Dr. Singh creates the conditions for the reader to achieve the empathetic identification with the plays' social worlds that is the basis of rasa-experience.

## B. Dhvani Theory (Anandavardhana)

In Dr. Singh's critical essays, dhvani (suggestion) operates at two levels. At the level of individual literary analysis, it is the mechanism by which he identifies the deeper social meanings of dramatic texts: the mythological allegory of 'Karn' (Surya-Kunti as upper-caste male/lower-caste woman) is an instance of what Anandavardhana calls aropita dhvani (dhvani by superimposition), where a secondary meaning supplants the primary. At the level of the essays themselves as critical texts, dhvani operates through the selection and juxtaposition of quotations: by placing the dialogue of oppressed women from different plays in sequence, without connecting commentary, Dr. Singh creates a cumulative effect in which the repeated structure of oppression becomes suggestive of a systemic pattern — the literary equivalent of Anandavardhana's concept of vaakyaartha dhvani (suggestion operating at the level of the whole text rather than individual words).

## C. Vakrokti (Kuntaka)

In Dr. Singh's poetry, vakrokti (oblique expression) is most consistently operative in 'Lori', where the lullaby form (a genre conventionally associated with comfort, security, and maternal love) is turned against itself to expose the absence of these very conditions for the poor child-speaker. The poem's formal 'twist' is precisely what Kuntaka means by vakrata (the turned, the oblique): the genre's conventional expectations are established only to be violated, and the violation is the poem's expressive engine. In his critical essays, vakrokti operates through ironic juxtaposition: the quoted dialogue of the oppressive husband or corrupt politician is placed against the background of stated social ideals, and the gap between them is the essay's critical thrust.

# VI. WESTERN LITERARY-CRITICAL FRAMEWORKS

## A. Marxist and Materialist Criticism

Dr. Singh's doctoral research on the social themes of Maithili drama is, in method and orientation, broadly consistent with Marxist literary criticism as theorised by Georg Lukacs and Raymond Williams. His essays on poverty and women's oppression in Maithili drama treat literary texts as social documents: their value lies not in formal innovation but in their capacity to represent, analyse, and critique the social conditions of their time. This is Lukacsian realism: the literary work's truth-value is measured by its fidelity to the 'totality' of social life, including its structural contradictions and its class dynamics.

The specific attention to how Maithili dramatists depict the landless labourer, the exploited woman, the child bride — and how the dramatic form creates conditions for the audience's critical engagement with these conditions — is consistent with Bertolt Brecht's theory of the social function of theatre. Brecht's concept of Verfremdungseffekt (defamiliarisation, alienation effect) — the theatrical device that prevents the audience from simply identifying emotionally with the characters, compelling them instead to think critically about the social conditions presented — can be applied to several of the plays Dr. Singh analyses. The use of allegorical characters in 'Karn', the direct address of the audience in some of the social dramas, and the deployment of folk song and lullaby forms in hybrid dramatic texts all constitute moments of Brechtian defamiliarisation within Maithili theatre.

## B. Postcolonial and Subaltern Studies

The discipline of translation studies within postcolonial theory (as theorised by Tejaswini Niranjana in 'Siting Translation', 1992, and Ganesh Devy in 'After Amnesia', 1992) is directly relevant to Dr. Singh's translatorial project. Niranjana's argument that colonial translation practices constructed a knowable, manageable 'Orient' through the translation choices of British scholars has a structural parallel in the dominance of Hindi-to-Maithili translation in the Maithili tradition: the flow of translation in one direction (from dominant languages into Maithili, rather than from smaller languages into Maithili) can reinforce a hierarchy of literary value. Dr. Singh's Konkani-to-Maithili translation disrupts this hierarchy by introducing a small language's

literary achievement into the Maithili world without routing it through Hindi's prestige.

Ganesh Devy's argument for 'translation as self-discovery' — the idea that translating another literature forces a language to discover its own capacities for expression that were previously dormant — is also relevant. The Maithili translation of 'Pakhalo' required Dr. Singh to find Maithili equivalents for Goan social realities (the Catholic family structure, the Goan landscape, the specific registers of Konkani daily life) that have no ready-made counterpart in the Maithili lexicon. This lexical and cultural stretching is precisely the kind of 'self-discovery' Devy identifies.

## C. Feminist Theory and Gender Studies

Dr. Singh's essays on women's oppression in Maithili drama engage implicitly with the frameworks developed by feminist theorists including Simone de Beauvoir ('The Second Sex', 1949), Adrienne Rich ('Of Woman Born', 1976), and the Indian feminist tradition as represented by Uma Chakravarti ('Rewriting History', 1998). De Beauvoir's fundamental thesis — that woman is constituted as 'Other' within patriarchal culture, defined not by her own subjectivity but by her difference from the male norm — is structurally enacted by the Maithili plays Dr. Singh analyses: the wife is defined by her failure to bring sufficient dowry, the widow by the absence of her husband, the child bride by her function in the family's social strategy.

The essay's identification of the paradox of the 'Yatra Naaryastu Poojyante' tradition — a culture that formally venerates women while practically subjecting them to systematic violence — is consistent with Uma Chakravarti's analysis of Brahmanical patriarchy as a system that uses religious ideology to mystify its own operation. The Maithili plays' sustained critique of this ideological mystification is what Dr. Singh identifies as their social-critical value.

## D. Reception Theory and the Sociology of Literature

Hans Robert Jauss's concept of the 'horizon of expectations' ('Toward an Aesthetic of Reception', 1982) is illuminating for understanding Dr. Singh's pedagogical essays. The horizon of expectations for a UPSC candidate approaching Maithili literary history is likely to be shaped by the dominant textbooks and reference materials in Hindi, which treat Maithili as a sub-regional variant of a broader Hindi tradition rather than as an independent literary culture. Dr. Singh's essays, by providing a detailed, internally coherent

account of Maithili literary periodisation grounded in Maithili scholarship, seek to transform this horizon of expectations: to train readers to understand Maithili literature on its own terms, from within its own intellectual tradition.

Pierre Bourdieu's sociology of cultural production ('The Rules of Art', 1992) is also relevant to the institutional dimension of Dr. Singh's career. His position at CIIL Mysore as Educational Consultant for the National Translation Mission places him at the intersection of the academic, governmental, and cultural fields: he is simultaneously a scholar, a state-employed language professional, and a creative writer. This complex institutional positioning — neither fully within the literary field (which is centred in Darbhanga, Patna, and Delhi) nor fully outside it — is itself a form of subaltern positioning within the Maithili cultural field, consistent with the Videha Parallel History Framework's interest in voices and careers that exist at the margins of the dominant institution.

## VII. THEMATIC SYNTHESIS: THE SCHOLAR AS CULTURAL WORKER

A central theme that unifies Dr. Shambhu Kumar Singh's diverse output — the historical essays, the drama criticism, the translation, the poetry, the memoir — is the figure of the scholar-as-cultural-worker: someone whose intellectual labour is inseparable from a commitment to the vitality, accessibility, and democratic expansion of Maithili literary culture. This figure stands in contrast to two other paradigmatic positions in the Maithili literary field: the 'great creative writer' (kavishwar, mahakavi) who is celebrated for original creative achievement, and the 'orthodox scholar' (vidwan, mahapandit) who guards the classical tradition's standards. Dr. Singh occupies neither of these positions but a third one: the worker who translates, explains, contextualises, and transmits.

The UPSC-directed essays are perhaps the clearest expression of this orientation. By framing complex literary-historical knowledge as 'useful for competitive examinees,' Dr. Singh explicitly democratises knowledge that has been restricted to an academic elite. This is not mere popularisation (a charge sometimes levelled at accessible scholarship) but a genuine act of pedagogical democratisation: the knowledge of Maithili literary history is not dumbed down but made available to a wider audience without condescension.

The translation of 'Pakhalo' extends this cultural-worker orientation into the domain of inter-literary hospitality. Dr. Singh's Maithili readers, through his

translation, have access to a Goan story that would otherwise be entirely unknown to them. This act of literary hospitality — giving the unfamiliar and distant a home in one's own language — is one of the functions of literature that is most easily overlooked in accounts of 'national' literary traditions, which tend to focus on self-expression rather than welcome of the other. Dr. Singh's translation practice is thus a form of what philosopher Luce Irigaray calls 'wonder' — the ethical and cognitive openness to the irreducibly different other.

The memoir-poem 'Smriti Shesh' adds a personal dimension to this synthesis: the cultural worker's labour is nourished by personal encounter, by the chain of human transmission through which literary culture is actually maintained — not only through the formal institutions of the academy and the press but through the informal relationships of greeting, recognition, and blessing that connect one generation of Maithili literary workers to another. The packet of moong dal is the symbol of this informal cultural economy: the fragrance of home-ground lentils carries a world within it that no institutional affiliation can replicate.

## VIII. ASSESSMENT: STRENGTHS, LIMITATIONS, AND SIGNIFICANCE

### A. Strengths

Dr. Shambhu Kumar Singh's primary strengths as a Maithili literary figure are: (1) his scholarly rigour, particularly in the literary-historical essays, which demonstrate genuine analytical independence from the received positions rather than mere reportage; (2) his pedagogical commitment, expressed in the UPSC-directed framing of complex material and in the clarity of his expository prose; (3) his cross-linguistic reach, demonstrated by the 'Pakhalo' translation project, which opens Maithili literary culture to an inter-regional conversation; (4) his thematic range in the drama essays, which cover poverty, women's oppression, child marriage, dowry, and sexual exploitation with consistent scholarly attention and direct textual grounding; (5) the lyric delicacy of his best poetry, particularly 'Lori' and 'Smriti Shesh', which achieve a genuine synthesis of personal emotion and social observation; and (6) his institutional position as a representative of Maithili at the National Translation Mission,

which has produced lasting infrastructural value for the language through the production of knowledge textbooks.

## B. Limitations

Relative to the most demanding standards of either creative or scholarly achievement, some limitations are observable: (1) the doctoral-thesis essays, while rigorously documented, are somewhat formulaic in structure — they enumerate rather than synthesise, and occasionally substitute survey for analysis; (2) the poetry, while sincere and formally accomplished, does not consistently achieve the level of formal innovation that the most distinguished Maithili poets (Vidyapati, Manmohana, Chandranath Mishra) have established; (3) the translation's indirect route through Hindi is a limitation that Dr. Singh himself acknowledges, and its effect on the Maithili version's fidelity to the Konkani original's register cannot be fully assessed without a comparative analysis that lies beyond the scope of this appreciation.

## C. Significance within the Videha Parallel History Framework

Within the Videha Parallel History Framework, Dr. Shambhu Kumar Singh's significance is substantial and distinctive. He represents the paradigmatic case of the scholar-translator who performs the intellectual infrastructure of a literary culture: without such figures, the literary tradition cannot document itself, transmit itself to new audiences, or engage with the literary traditions of other languages and communities. His work in the National Translation Mission has contributed directly to the constitutionally mandated goal of making knowledge available in Maithili; his doctoral research has produced a systematic account of Maithili social drama's engagement with the pressing concerns of poverty and gender justice; his translation of 'Pakhalo' has expanded the horizon of what Maithili readers can access.

His memoir 'Smriti Shesh' is, within the Videha archive, a document of cultural transmission: it records a moment in the informal chain of literary continuity through which the great scholars and writers of one generation pass their blessing ('jeebu! khub tarakki karu!' — 'live and flourish!') to the younger workers of the next. This chain of transmission — from Prof. Anima Singh's blessing to Dr. Singh's continued labour — is itself a form of literary history, one that the formal institutions of canon and award have difficulty recording but that Videha, with its commitment to the full and democratic account of Maithili literary life, is designed to preserve.

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**LESSON 080 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**

# CRITICAL APPRECIATONS

SHANTI LAKSHMI CHAUDHARY & RAJEEV RANJAN MISHRA

Feminist Poet-Essayist · Ghazal Poet & Devotional Composer

## WHAT THE CANON LEFT OUT

A Parallel History of Mithila & Maithili Literature

Gajendra Thakur

# A PARALLEL HISTORY OF MAITHILI LITERATURE

CRITICAL APPRECIATIONS

**SHANTI LAKSHMI CHAUDHARY & RAJEEV RANJAN MISHRA**

*Feminist Poet-Essayist · Ghazal Poet & Devotional Composer*

*Indian & Western Literary Theory · Videha Parallel History Framework*

*Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa · Rasa-Dhvani-Vakrokti-Auchitya*

# PART ONE: SHANTI LAKSHMI CHAUDHARY

## I. BIOGRAPHICAL PROFILE

### A. Identity and Formation

Shanti Lakshmi Chaudhary (शान्तिलक्ष्मी चौधरी / शान्ति लक्ष्मी चौधरी) is a Maithili poet, essayist, and cultural critic — one of the most distinctive feminist voices in the Videha Parallel History's literary archive. Her presence across at least six Videha Sadeha volumes (Sadeha 7, 9, 11, 13, 14, and 15) spanning multiple literary genres — haiku, prose poetry, ghazal, nature poetry, children's poetry (bāla ghazal), cultural essays, and feminist-theoretical criticism — marks her as one of the most generically versatile writers in the Videha community.

Her surname Chaudhary indicates origins in the Chaudhary community of Mithila — a community with a strong presence in the Madhubani district and the broader Mithila region, historically associated with agricultural and administrative roles. The name Shanti Lakshmi (Peace + the goddess of prosperity) encodes the traditional Maithili dual naming practice, but her literary work systematically interrogates the social assumptions embedded in such traditional identities.

### B. Videha Archive: Complete Works Catalogue

Videha Sadeha 7 (Prelim_7): Haiku / Prose poetry / Tilakora, Bathuāka Tīmana, Ghazal 1–8. This is her most genre-diverse single contribution: haiku (the ultra-short form), prose poetry (gadya kavitā), and eight ghazals alongside nature-food poetry (Tilakora — taro; Bathuāka Tīmana — a Maithili leafy vegetable).

Videha Sadeha 9 (Prelim_9): Bāla Ghazal 1–4 / Kumhar / Barkha Rānī. Children's ghazals alongside the nature poems Kumhar (Potter) and Barkha Rānī (Rain Queen) — demonstrating engagement with the pedagogical and children's literary strand of Videha.

Videha Sadeha 11 (Prelim_11): Ghazal 1–4. Standard adult ghazal contribution.

Videha Sadeha 13 (Prelim_13): Jar-Jājan / Durgāpūjā. Cultural-devotional poetry — Jar-Jājan is a traditional Maithili ritual associated with ancestral worship; Durgāpūjā engages with the major Shakta festival from a Maithili perspective.

Videha Sadeha 14 (Prelim_14): Matibhrama (मतिभ्रम — Confusion of Mind / Delusion), pp. 568–569. A short prose or verse piece on cognitive-moral confusion.

Videha Sadeha 15 (Prelim_15): Lesbian Continuum (लेस्बियन कॉन्टिन्युअम) / Mātr̥tva (Motherhood) / Netājī (The Leader), pp. 159–172 — fourteen pages, the longest single contribution documented in the archive.

## II. THEMATIC AND GENERIC ANALYSIS

### A. The 'Lesbian Continuum' Essay: A Landmark in Maithili Feminist Criticism

Shanti Lakshmi Chaudhary's 'Lesbian Continuum' (लेस्बियन कॉन्टिन्युअम) — published in Videha Sadeha 15 alongside 'Mātr̥tva' (Motherhood) and 'Netājī' — is among the most theoretically ambitious pieces of feminist writing in the Maithili digital archive. The very title — using the English phrase 'Lesbian Continuum' as a Maithili theoretical concept — signals a direct engagement with Adrienne Rich's groundbreaking 1980 essay 'Compulsory Heterosexuality and Lesbian Existence', in which Rich introduced 'lesbian continuum' as a concept encompassing all woman-identified experience and woman-woman bonds, not merely sexual relationships.

The deployment of this theoretical concept in Maithili — in a journal published from Mithila, Bihar — is a remarkable act of intellectual cross-cultural translation. Rich's 'lesbian continuum' was developed in a Western feminist context but has broad cross-cultural applicability: its central argument is that heterosexuality is a compulsory social institution rather than a natural or inevitable condition, and that the history of women's culture includes a wide spectrum of woman-identified relationships that patriarchal history has suppressed or ignored. In the Maithili context, this argument resonates with the history of women's oral culture — the folk songs, the Madhubani painting tradition, the women's ritual practices (Madhushravani, Bhat-puja, the sohara tradition) that constitute a distinct female sphere of cultural production within Mithila's gendered social structure.

The three pieces together — Lesbian Continuum, Mātr̥tva, Netājī — form a feminist triptych: the first addresses women's horizontal solidarity and the critique of compulsory heterosexuality; the second addresses the ideology of motherhood; the third (Netājī, literally 'the revered leader') is presumably a satirical or critical examination of political leadership, completing a critique of three patriarchal institutions (the compulsory heterosexual family, idealised motherhood, and male political authority).

## B. Nature Poetry and the Mithila Ecological Imagination

Chaudhary's nature poetry — Tilakora, Bathuāka Tīmana, Kumhar, Barkha Rānī — belongs to a strand of Maithili poetic practice that treats the local agricultural and ecological universe of Mithila as the primary substance of literary imagination. Tilakora (taro plant/colocasia) and Bathūā (Chenopodium/pigweed, eaten as leafy greens in Maithili cooking) are not merely peasant subjects but specific presences in the Mithila kitchen-garden landscape that carry cultural, nutritional, and social meanings. Writing poetry about Bathūāka Tīmana (the cooked dish of Bathūā leaves) treats the everyday culinary practice of Mithila as a worthy subject of literary attention — a democratic aesthetic move consistent with the Parallel History's commitment to the fullness of Maithili community life.

Barkha Rānī (Rain Queen) personifies the monsoon as a female sovereign — a move consistent with the Indian tradition of gendering natural forces and consistent also with the feminist implications of elevating the feminine in the natural and cosmological order. Kumhar (Potter) suggests an engagement with the craft tradition of Mithila, specifically the potter community whose earthenware is foundational to Maithili ritual and domestic life.

### C. Children's Poetry and the Bāla Ghazal

Chaudhary's bāla ghazal (children's ghazal) contributions in Sadeha 9 — alongside Kumhar and Barkha Rānī — represent her engagement with the pedagogical-literary project of developing Maithili children's literature. The bāla ghazal is a Videha innovation: the ghazal form, adapted for children with simpler vocabulary, accessible imagery, and playful themes while maintaining the formal structure of bahr and radif. This pedagogy-through-form approach is consistent with Gajendra Thakur's editorial philosophy of using Videha to develop every literary form, genre, and demographic register of Maithili.

### D. Ghazal: Register and Style

Her ghazal contributions span multiple Sadeha volumes (7, 11, 14, 15) and include both ghazals in the standard adult register and the children's ghazals (Sadeha 9). Her Sadeha 7 contribution of eight ghazals alongside haiku and prose poetry demonstrates a poet who treats formal diversity — the short (haiku), the medium (ghazal), and the unstructured (prose poetry) — as complementary instruments in a single creative practice. The juxtaposition of the haiku's imagistic compression with the ghazal's two-line sher-by-sher structure and the prose poem's expansive non-metrical space suggests a poet consciously exploring the different modes of lyric attention.

## III. THEORETICAL FRAMEWORKS

### A. Adrienne Rich and Feminist Continuum Theory

Adrienne Rich's 'Compulsory Heterosexuality and Lesbian Existence' (1980) is the direct theoretical source for Chaudhary's most significant essay. Rich argues that heterosexuality is a political institution enforced through social, economic, and cultural mechanisms rather than a natural given; that 'lesbian existence' is a fact of history that has been suppressed; and that the 'lesbian continuum' names the full range of woman-identified experience — from same-sex relationships to women's friendship, solidarity, and cultural production. For Chaudhary, translating this framework into Maithili criticism is an act of asserting that Maithili women's culture — including its folk song traditions, painting practices, and ritual life — has its own lesbian continuum that has not been adequately theorised.

Elaine Showalter's gynocriticism (A Literature of Their Own, 1977) provides a complementary framework: the project of recovering and theorising women's literary tradition as a distinct body with its own aesthetic practices and cultural logic, distinct from the male-dominated canonical tradition. Chaudhary's work in the Videha archive is gynocritic in Showalter's sense: it produces literary-critical and creative work that centres women's experience and women's cultural forms.

## B. Navya-Nyāya and the Epistemology of Feminist Knowledge

Gaṅgeśa's Tattvacintāmaṇi's analysis of pratyakṣa (direct perception) as the most reliable pramāṇa is relevant to feminist epistemology in a specific way. Feminist standpoint theory — particularly Sandra Harding's argument (The Science Question in Feminism, 1986) that knowledge produced from the standpoint of the oppressed is epistemically privileged because it has access to realities that the dominant group systematically ignores — parallels the Navya-Nyāya's emphasis on the reliability of direct perception by a competent observer. The feminist poet's pratyakṣa of women's experience — the direct, embodied knowledge of what it means to be a woman in Mithila's patriarchal social structure — constitutes a form of pramāṇa that the canonical literary tradition's male-dominated śabda-pramāṇa cannot replicate.

Chaudhary's Lesbian Continuum essay and Mātṛtva piece constitute anumāna (inferential) arguments from observed social facts (the structure of women's relationships and the ideology of motherhood in Maithili society) to general conclusions about the nature of patriarchal compulsion and women's alternative solidarities. The vyāpti (universal concomitance) underlying these arguments is: wherever patriarchal institutions are present, they enforce normative heterosexuality and idealised maternity; in Maithili society, these institutions are present; therefore they operate in Maithili society in these specific ways.

## C. Indian Alaṃkāra Tradition: Feminist Vakrokti

Kuntaka's vakrokti (oblique expression as the essence of poetic language) acquires a specifically feminist dimension in Chaudhary's work. The deployment of a Western theoretical term (Lesbian Continuum) in a Maithili essay is itself a form of vakrokti: it refuses the expected vocabulary of the dominant tradition (Sanskrit-Maithili literary criticism) and uses an oblique, foreign term to create a cognitive shock that focuses attention on the concept being introduced. This is vakrokti in the literary sense: unexpected expression that creates new perception.

Her nature poems — treating Bathūā and Tilakora as poetic subjects — are also vakrokti in the social sense: they use the ordinary, low-prestige domestic subjects of Mithila's peasant economy as the vehicle for literary attention, creating a formal incongruity (high literary form + low peasant subject) that functions as a feminist critique of the hierarchy that distinguishes 'worthy' from 'unworthy' poetic subjects.

### D. Videha Parallel History Framework

Shanti Lakshmi Chaudhary is a paradigmatic figure for the Videha Parallel History's feminist strand. The Framework's founding commitment to subaltern, Dalit, and women's voices in Maithili literature is enacted in Chaudhary's corpus. Her Lesbian Continuum essay brings radical feminist theory into Maithili literary discourse; her nature poetry valorises the domestic female sphere of Mithila's ecological culture; her children's poetry contributes to the project of building a Maithili children's literary tradition; and her ghazals add a female voice to the predominantly male ghazal tradition in the Videha archive.

Her Prelim_14 piece 'Matibhrama' (Confusion/Delusion) is a title that resonates with the feminist critique of false consciousness — the question of whose values and whose reality constitute the normative framework that women are expected to accept. In a tradition where women's poetry has been largely confined to devotional and domestic registers, Chaudhary's theoretical and satirical ambition (the Netājī essay as political satire) represents a significant expansion of the Maithili women's literary tradition.

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# PART TWO: RAJEEV RANJAN MISHRA

## V. BIOGRAPHICAL PROFILE

### A. Identity and Formation

Rajeev Ranjan Mishra (राजीव रंजन मिश्र) is a Maithili poet, ghazal writer, and lyricist who appears across six Videha Sadeha volumes (Sadeha 7, 12, 14, 15, 16, and 20) — one of the most consistent presences in the Videha ghazal archive alongside the more extensively documented figures of Ashish Anchinhar and Kundan Kumar Karn. His contributions span: the standard ghazal tradition, devotional/bhakti ghazal, the Janakī gīta (devotional song to Sita/Janaki), the Faguā (Holi songs), Jogīrā (another Holi-associated form), and the muktaka (free verse quatrain). This generic range — from the formal rigour of the ghazal to the performative festivity of the Faguā and Jogīrā — marks him as a poet with roots in both the literary and the folk-performative traditions of Mithila.

His surname Mishra identifies him within the Maithil Brahmin community — one of the most prominent community surnames in Maithili literature. The coupling of the Brahmin surname with the Faguā/Jogīrā folk forms in his Sadeha 20 contribution is culturally significant: these Holi-associated performative forms traditionally cross caste boundaries and are associated with communal festivity and social inversion.

### B. Videha Archive: Complete Works Catalogue

Videha Sadeha 7 (Prelim_7): Bhakti Ghazal (भक्ति गजल) — devotional ghazal, the most ancient register of the Arabic-Persian ghazal tradition as adapted in the Indian Sufi context.

Videha Sadeha 12 (Prelim_12): Ghazal 1–4 — four standard ghazals, his earliest numbered contribution.

Videha Sadeha 14 (Prelim_14): Ghazal + Jānakī Gīta (जानकी गीत), pp. 522–523. The Jānakī Gīta (song to Jānakī/Sita) is of particular significance: Sita/Jānakī is the presiding divine figure of Mithila (her birthplace), and devotional composition to her is the most locally rooted of all Maithili literary-religious practices.

Videha Sadeha 15 (Prelim_15): Kichu Ghazal (Some Ghazals), pp. 257–258.

Videha Sadeha 16 (Prelim_16): Ghazal, p. 727.

Videha Sadeha 20 (Prelim_20): Faguā (मुक्तक) / Jogīrā / Kichu Ghazal, pp. 861–876 — sixteen pages, his most substantial contribution; the Holi-song forms occupy the major part.

# VI. THEMATIC AND GENERIC ANALYSIS

## A. The Bhakti Ghazal: Devotional and Classical

Rajeev Ranjan Mishra's first documented Videha contribution is a Bhakti Ghazal — a devotional ghazal in the tradition that runs from the Sufi Persian masters through the Bhakti saints of Hindi literature (Kabir, Mirabai) to the modern Hindi-Urdu ghazal's sustained devotional strand. The Bhakti ghazal in the Maithili context is complexly positioned: it inherits both the Arabic-Persian mystical ghazal's tradition of the beloved as divine (in Sufi poetry, the lover's longing for the beloved mirrors the soul's longing for God) and the Maithili Vaishnava tradition's celebration of Krishna-Radha devotional love as the primary vehicle of spiritual experience.

Vidyapati's padāvalī — the foundational body of Maithili devotional poetry — is itself a form of bhakti composition in which the erotic and the devotional are inseparable: the lover's longing for Radha and Krishna is simultaneously human and divine, sensual and transcendent. Mishra's bhakti ghazal thus positions itself within this long tradition while using the formal structure of the Arabic-Persian ghazal rather than the native Maithili padā form.

## B. The Jānakī Gīta: Sita in Mithila

The Jānakī Gīta (Song to Jānakī) in Sadeha 14 is Mishra's most culturally specific contribution. Jānakī (Sita as the daughter of Janaka, King of Mithila) is the most locally resonant of all Maithili divine figures — she was born in the soil of Mithila (specifically at Janakpur, now in Nepal), and her story is the story of Mithila itself. The Videha journal itself is named for Videha, the ancient kingdom of which Mithila was the capital — the same kingdom over which King Janaka ruled and in which Sita was born.

Composing a gīta to Jānakī is thus the most direct act of cultural rootedness available to a Maithili poet. The Videha Parallel History Framework's engagement with Videha/Janaka/Sita as the foundational mythological

complex of Mithila gives the Jānakī Gīta genre a specific significance: it is not merely devotional but constitutively Maithili — a genre that can only exist within the Mithila cultural tradition.

### C. Faguā and Jogīrā: The Folk-Festive Register

The sixteen-page contribution in Sadeha 20 — Faguā (muktaka) / Jogīrā / Kichu Ghazal — is Mishra's most generically ambitious piece. The Faguā is the Holi song tradition of Mithila: songs of festivity, social inversion, teasing, and communal celebration sung during the Holi festival. The muktaka form is a freely structured quatrain — rhyming AABA or AAAA — that allows for brief, epigrammatic statements. The Jogīrā is a more specifically Bhojpuri-Maithili festive form associated with Holi performances, with a call-and-response structure.

The juxtaposition of the formal ghazal with the folk-festive Faguā and Jogīrā in a single Videha contribution is a deliberate generic mixing that reflects the Parallel History's democratic aesthetic: the high form (ghazal, with its Arabic-Persian heritage and strict prosodic requirements) and the low form (Faguā/Jogīrā, rooted in the oral festive tradition) are equally valued and equally present in the Videha archive.

## VII. THEORETICAL FRAMEWORKS

### A. Rasa Analysis: Bhakti, Śṛṅgāra, and Hāsya

Bharatamuni's rasa theory provides the primary Indian critical framework for Mishra's multi-register corpus. His bhakti ghazal and Jānakī gīta operate in the Śānta-rasa (devotional tranquillity) and Śṛṅgāra-rasa (erotic-devotional love) registers of the Bhakti tradition. The Faguā and Jogīrā Holi songs operate in Hāsya-rasa (comic festivity) — the register of Holi's traditional social inversion and communal playfulness. The standard ghazals of Sadeha 12, 15, and 16 typically operate in mixed registers of Karuṇa (pathos) and Śṛṅgāra (love).

The capacity to move across these three very different rasa-registers — the devotional-transcendent, the festive-comic, and the lyric-amorous — within a single Videha corpus marks Mishra as a poet of genuine generic breadth. This range is precisely what the Videha Parallel History Framework aims to document: the democratic fullness of Maithili literary practice, which is not confined to any single emotional or formal register.

## B. Navya-Nyāya: Śabda-Pramāṇa and the Devotional Tradition

The bhakti ghazal and Jānakī gīta operate within the Maithili devotional tradition's understanding of śabda-pramāṇa (verbal testimony as valid knowledge). In the devotional context, the sacred text — whether the Vedas, the Puranas, or the devotional compositions of Vidyapati — constitutes the highest form of śabda-pramāṇa: testimony that transmits direct knowledge of the divine. The poet who composes a new bhakti ghazal or Jānakī gīta is claiming a position within this śabda-pramāṇa tradition: adding their testimony to the accumulated chain of valid verbal knowledge about the divine.

Gaṅgeśa's analysis of the conditions for valid śabda — the speaker's tattvajñāna (knowledge of the truth) and their vivakṣā (intention to communicate it truly) — applies here: the bhakti poet's authority rests on their claimed experiential knowledge of the divine (tattvajñāna through devotion) and their sincere intention to communicate that knowledge through the poem (vivakṣā in the devotional act of composition).

## C. Mikhail Bakhtin: Carnivalesque and Generic Mixing

Mikhail Bakhtin's concept of the carnivalesque (Rabelais and His World, 1965; Problems of Dostoevsky's Poetics, 1929) provides a framework for the Faguā and Jogīrā contributions. The carnival, for Bakhtin, is a form of festive inversion in which normal social hierarchies are temporarily suspended, the low is elevated and the high is debased, and the communal body asserts itself against the hierarchical social order. The Holi festival in Bihar and Mithila is precisely a carnivalesque event in Bakhtin's sense: the social inversions of Holi — the licensed teasing of authority figures, the crossing of caste and gender boundaries in the communal celebration, the festive debasement of the sacred — are encoded in the Faguā and Jogīrā song forms that Mishra composes.

Bakhtin's concept of generic heteroglossia — the coexistence of multiple social voices and registers within a single literary work — is directly applicable to Mishra's Sadeha 20 contribution: the dignified muktaka, the playful Faguā, and the performative Jogīrā coexist within a single literary contribution, creating a dialogic text in which the formal and the festive, the literary and the oral, engage in productive tension.

## D. Videha Parallel History Framework

Rajeev Ranjan Mishra's corpus represents the Parallel History's most consistent ghazal tradition — spanning six Sadeha volumes and demonstrating sustained

engagement with the form over multiple years. His inclusion of the Bhakti ghazal, the Jānakī gīta, and the Faguā/Jogīrā alongside the standard ghazal forms enacts the Parallel History's democratic aesthetic: all forms, from the Sanskrit-Bhakti tradition to the folk-festive oral tradition, are equally worthy of inclusion in the Maithili literary archive.

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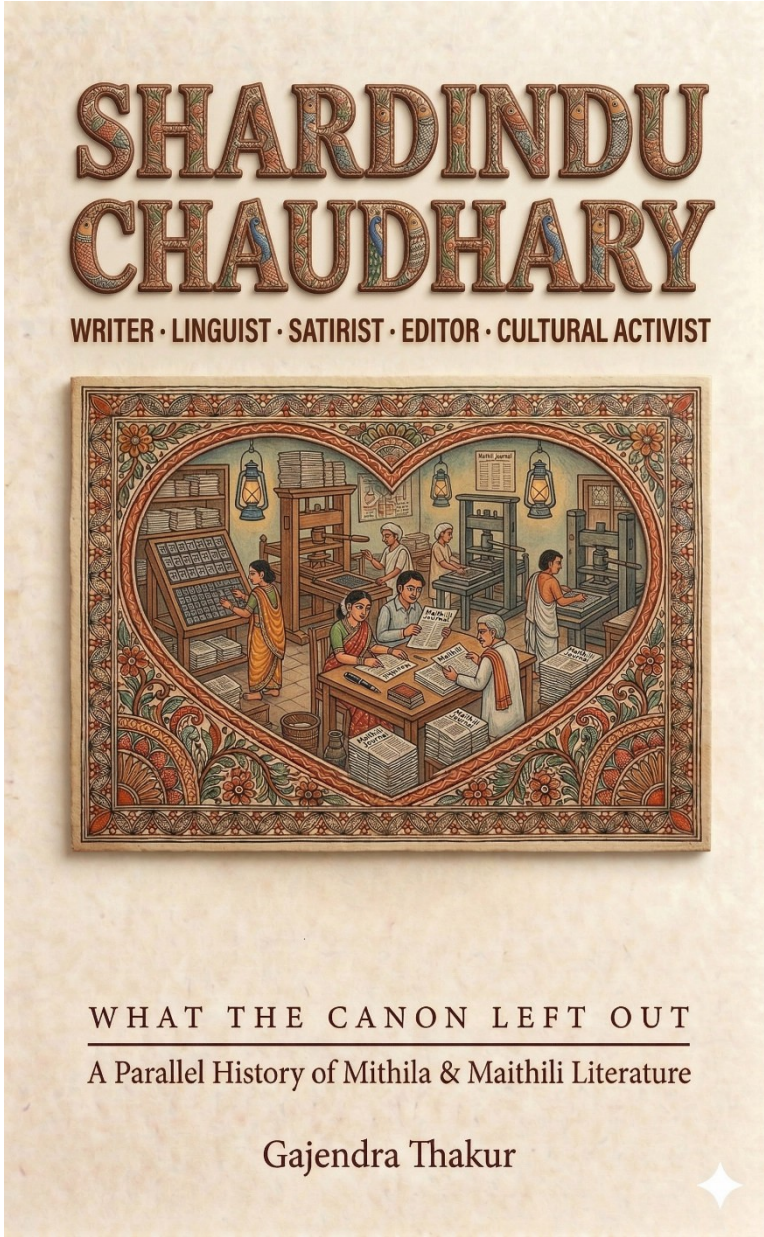
**LESSON 081 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**



# Shardindu Chaudhary

*Writer · Linguist · Satirist · Editor · Cultural Activist*

## 1. Biographical Profile at a Glance

The following facts are drawn from the formal profile in Videha 358 (presented by Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil', pp. 15–20), the interview (pp. 21–25), and corroborating cross-references across the Videha archive.

| | |
|---|---|
| **Full Name** | Shardindu Kumar Chaudhary (also: Sharadindu Chaudhary / Shardu Ji) |
| **Affectionate Address** | 'Shardu Bhaiya' (elder brother Shardu) — used by peers including Kedar Kanan and Vibha Rani |
| **Language** | Maithili — the classical language of Mithila (north Bihar & Terai Nepal), 8th Schedule of the Indian Constitution |
| **Primary Genres** | Satirical prose (vyangya), comic memoir (hasy-sansmaran), short story, journalism, literary editing |
| **Editorial Role** | Editor, Samay-Sal — a significant Maithili periodical |
| **Archive Association** | Videha: Pratham Maithili Paksik eJournal (www.videha.co.in), ISSN 2229-547X — close association as contributor and archive facilitator |
| **Archive Courtesy** | Three works of Shivshankar Srinivas archived in Videha with joint courtesy of 'Shivshankar Srinivas and Shardindu Chaudhary' |
| **Videha Special Issue** | Videha No. 358, 15 November 2022 — an entire issue dedicated to him during his lifetime |
| **Public Reception** | Readers on social media declared this issue more significant than Sahitya Akademi / Lalit Kala |

| | |
|---|---|
| | Akademi / Sangeet Natak Akademi awards (recorded by editor Gajendra Thakur, p. 1) |
| **Key Literary Period** | Active primarily from the late 20th century through the early 21st century; Kariya Kakkak Coramin published 2016 |

## 2. The Videha Special Issue 358: Context and Significance

Videha (www.videha.co.in), founded in 2000 by Gajendra Thakur as 'Bhalsarik Gachh' and formally named Videha from 1 January 2008, is the first Maithili internet periodical (ISSN 2229-547X). It has been published twice monthly since its inception and has become the primary platform of the Videha Maithili Sahitya Aandolan — the Videha Maithili Literature Movement — which positions itself as a 'parallel tradition' running independently of the institutional mainstream.

Within this movement, the practice of publishing living-writer special issues (visheshank) has been a key mode of recognition. Issue 358 (15 November 2022, Year 15, Issue 179) is dedicated to Shardindu Chaudhary. The editor Gajendra Thakur records in the editorial that readers on social media declared this special issue more meaningful than awards from the Sahitya Akademi, Lalit Kala Akademi, or Sangeet Natak Akademi — India's three premier cultural institutions. This reception itself is a significant critical statement about the relative value placed on peer recognition versus institutional endorsement within the Maithili literary community.

The issue contains twenty-two dedicated essays, a profile, an interview, and three extended critical analyses by Gajendra Thakur — spanning pages 11 to 134 of the issue — making it the most comprehensive documentary source on Shardindu Chaudhary's life and work.

### 2.1 Contributors and Their Essays: Full Index

The following essays constitute the Shardindu Chaudhary Visheshank:

- 2.1 — Context of the special issue (pp. 12–14)

- 2.2 — Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil': Profile of Shardindu Chaudhary (pp. 15–20)
- 2.3 — Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil': Interview with Shardindu Chaudhary (pp. 21–25)
- 2.4 — Kalpana Jha: 'Maithili Sahityak Sewak Nahin, Maithili Bhasak Sewak: Shardindu Chaudhary' (pp. 26–30)
- 2.5 — Ram Bharos Kapadi 'Bhramar': 'Hamar Gyan-Pipashak Srot: Shardindu Chaudhary' (pp. 31–34)
- 2.6 — Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil': 'Ohina Nahin Tamasait Chhathi Shardindu Chaudhary' (pp. 35–38)
- 2.7 — Vibha Rani: 'Shardu Bhaik Gambhir Siddhantapriyata!' (pp. 39–44)
- 2.8 — Dr. Narayanji: 'Visangatik Viruddha Pratirodhak-Swar' (pp. 45–47)
- 2.9 — Munni Kamat: 'Bhashavid Shri Shardindu Chaudhary' (pp. 48–50)
- 2.10 — Gaurinath: 'Shardindu Chaudhary Helak Maane' (pp. 51–55)
- 2.11 — Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil': 'Kathya, Tathya Aa Satyak Chintan' (pp. 56–62)
- 2.12 — Ajit Kumar Jha: 'Samay-Sal Ken Akanait: Shardindujik Sampadan O Sampadakiya' (pp. 63–69)
- 2.13 — Ashok: 'Shardindu Ji' (pp. 70–73)
- 2.14 — Shivshankara Srinivas: 'Jehne Madhur Tehne Dridh' (pp. 74–78)
- 2.15 — Kedar Kanan: 'Hamar Shardu Bhaiya' (pp. 79–82)
- 2.16 — Ashish Anchinhar: 'Maithili Sahityame Shardindu Chaudhary Ker Yogdan' (pp. 83–87)
- 2.17 — Gajendra Thakur: Critical analysis of memoir series Baat-Baat Par Baat (I–IV) (pp. 88–98)
- 2.18 — Gajendra Thakur: Critical analysis of Ja Ham Janitahun (pp. 99–106)
- 2.19 — Gajendra Thakur: Critical analysis of three satirical collections — Bad Ajagut Dekhal, Goharaganesh, Kariya Kakkak Coramin (pp. 107–112)
- 2.20 — Lakshmana Jha Sagar: 'Khanti Maithilist Shardu Ji!' (pp. 113–118)
- 2.21 — Jagadananda Jha 'Manu': 'Satya Dekhal' (pp. 119–124)
- 2.22 — Shrivaram: 'Shardindu Kumar Chaudhary Ker Sahitya: Swarth Laagi Karaphu Sab Priti' (pp. 125–134)

# 3. Works of Shardindu Chaudhary: A Comprehensive Catalogue

The following catalogue is compiled from critical analyses in Videha 358, the Videha pothi.htm archive, and the IJCRT academic survey of 21st-century Maithili short stories (October 2025, Bijayendra Jha). Where exact publication years are given in sources, they are noted; otherwise the approximate period of activity is given.

## 3.1 Works Table

| Year/ Period | Title | Genre | Notes |
|---|---|---|---|
| **c. 2010s** | *Baat-Baat Par Baat — Vol. I* | Memoir-essay | Sansmaran (reflective memoir); vol. 1 of 4-volume series |
| **c. 2010s** | *Baat-Baat Par Baat — Vol. II* | Memoir-essay | Vol. 2 of 4-volume series |
| **c. 2010s** | *Baat-Baat Par Baat — Vol. III* | Memoir-essay | Vol. 3 of 4-volume series |
| **c. 2010s** | *Baat-Baat Par Baat — Vol. IV* | Memoir-essay | Vol. 4; analysed Videha 358 pp. 88–98 by Gajendra Thakur |
| **c. 2015–20** | *Ja Ham Janitahun* | Satirical memoir | Title phrase: 'Had I known...' — comic-retrospective memoir; analysed Videha 358 pp. 99–106 |
| **c. 2015** | *Bad Ajagut Dekhal...* | Satire (vyangya) | 'I saw a great absurdity' — social satirical collection; |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | | analysed Videha 358 pp. 107–112 |
| **c. 2015** | *Goharaganesh* | Satire (vyangya) | Satirical collection; title invokes the comic archetype 'Gohara Ganesha'; analysed Videha 358 pp. 107–112 |
| **2016** | *Kariya Kakkak Coramin* | Satire / Short story | Cited in IJCRT survey 2025; analysed Videha 358 pp. 107–112; cross-ref. Videha 352 p. 101–106 |
| **ongoing** | *Editorials of Samay-Sal* | Periodical editorials | Analysed by Ajit Kumar Jha, Videha 358 pp. 63–69 as a substantial literary body of work |

## 3.2 The Satirical Collections: Critical Analysis

Gajendra Thakur's extended essay in Videha 358 (pp. 107–112) is the most detailed analysis of Shardindu Chaudhary's three satirical collections. They represent the sustained deployment of a comic-critical worldview across a significant body of work.

### *3.2.1 Bad Ajagut Dekhal...*

The title Bad Ajagut Dekhal — 'I saw a great/big absurdity' — announces the satirist's stance from the outset: the writer as observer, astonished by social, cultural and institutional absurdities. The ellipsis in the title itself is a gesture of open-endedness — the list of absurdities is infinite. The satirical-observer mode has deep roots in Maithili comic writing, going back to Harimohan Jha's (1908–1984) Khattar Kakak Tarang, in which the fictional 'uncle' Khattar Kaka systematically dismantles religious and social orthodoxies. Shardindu

Chaudhary works in this same tradition of the sharp-eyed commentator who sees through convention.

### *3.2.2 Goharaganesh*

The title invokes the figure of 'Gohara Ganesha' — a comic type associated with overconfident self-assertion and blundering officiousness. This title frames the collection as a series of portraits of such figures in contemporary Maithili and broader Indian social life. The use of mythological-folkloric reference as a framework for contemporary satire is characteristic of the best Maithili satirical writing.

### *3.2.3 Kariya Kakkak Coramin (2016)*

This is the most widely cited of Shardindu Chaudhary's works outside the Videha ecosystem. The IJCRT academic survey (Bijayendra Jha, October 2025, Vol. 13, Issue 10, ISSN 2320-2882) lists it among the significant short story / satirical collections of the period 2015–2020, placing Shardindu Chaudhary alongside Sahitya Akademi-awarded writers and other established names in a scholarly survey of more than 300 published collections. The title — Kariya Kakkak Coramin, meaning approximately 'the stomach-medicine of Black Uncle' — is characteristically comic, using the physical image of a purgative as metaphor for social cleansing or the discomfort of honest observation.

The Videha 358 critical essay by Gajendra Thakur (pp. 107–112) analyses all three collections as a unified body of satirical work, arguing for Shardindu Chaudhary's place in the first rank of Maithili satirists of his generation.

## 3.3 The Memoir Series: Baat-Baat Par Baat (I–IV)

Gajendra Thakur's critical essay (Videha 358, pp. 88–98) analyses the four-volume memoir-essay series Baat-Baat Par Baat — a title meaning 'Word upon Word' or 'Point by Point.' This extended series of reflective autobiographical-essayistic prose tracks Maithili cultural life, literary friendships, institutional politics, and personal experience over several decades. The four-volume structure suggests an ongoing, cumulative engagement with the memoir form rather than a single completed work.

The editor of Videha connects this memoir-writing to a broader valorisation of the sansmaran (memoir) genre, noting that the Nobel Prize in Literature in 2022 was awarded to Annie Ernaux specifically for her memoir writing — a pointed claim that Shardindu Chaudhary's sustained memoir-essay practice belongs to

an internationally significant literary mode, even if it has been overlooked by institutional bodies closer to home.

## 3.4 Ja Ham Janitahun

Analysed in Videha 358 (pp. 99–106), this satirical memoir collection takes its title from the Maithili expression 'Ja Ham Janitahun' — 'Had I known [this would happen]...' — a phrase charged with retrospective irony. The comic memoirs in this collection use the form of personal reminiscence inflected by the satirist's eye: the self becomes both the subject and the satirical object. This self-deprecating irony is a mark of the highest comic writing, since it requires the writer to turn the critical gaze inward without becoming purely self-indulgent.

## 3.5 Editorial Work: Samay-Sal

Ajit Kumar Jha's essay 'Samay-Sal Ken Akanait' (Videha 358, pp. 63–69) is the primary critical account of Shardindu Chaudhary's editorial work. Samay-Sal was a Maithili literary periodical; its name — 'Time-Tree/Season-Tree' — evokes both temporal awareness and rootedness in a cultural landscape. Ajit Kumar Jha argues that Shardindu Chaudhary's editorials deserve to be read as a substantial body of literary non-fiction in their own right — a claim that positions editorial writing as a primary literary genre rather than a secondary administrative function. Good editorial writing in Maithili has historically been under-recognized as a form of literary production, and Ajit Kumar Jha's essay is notable for treating Shardindu Chaudhary's editorials as substantive texts worthy of critical attention.

The history of Maithili literature has always been bound up with periodical culture. Major journals including Mithila Mihir, Vaidehi, Abhivyanjana, and Videha itself have been vehicles not just for carrying literary work but for forming taste, creating intellectual community, and articulating aesthetic positions. Samay-Sal occupies a place in this tradition.

# 4. Life, Personality and Intellectual Formation

## 4.1 Temperament: Equanimity and Principled Firmness

The portrait of Shardindu Chaudhary that emerges from the 22 essays in Videha 358 is unusually consistent. Multiple contributors across different generations and literary positions converge on a character defined by two seemingly opposed qualities: great personal warmth and absolute principled firmness. Shivshankara Srinivas captures this in his essay title 'Jehne Madhur Tehne Dridh' — 'As Sweet as He Is Resolute.'

Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil's essay 'Ohina Nahin Tamasait Chhathi Shardindu Chaudhary' — 'Shardindu Chaudhary does not get irritated like that' — describes a temperament that resists provocation and maintains steadiness. This quality is significant in a literary world where institutional politics, caste dynamics, and generational rivalries frequently generate heated controversy. Shardindu Chaudhary's ability to remain engaged without becoming irritable is presented as itself a form of moral and intellectual practice.

Vibha Rani's essay title 'Shardu Bhaik Gambhir Siddhantapriyata!' — 'Shardu Bhai's serious attachment to principles!' — is marked by an exclamation of admiration. The 'serious attachment to principles' she identifies is not puritanism but intellectual integrity: a commitment to saying what is true and correct regardless of social pressure.

Kedar Kanan's affectionate essay 'Hamar Shardu Bhaiya' — 'My Shardu Bhai' — presents a warmer, more fraternal picture. The use of the familial address 'Bhaiya' (elder brother) by a younger writer indicates the way Shardindu Chaudhary has functioned as a mentor and elder within the Maithili literary world, offering encouragement, guidance, and intellectual companionship.

## 4.2 The Linguistic Identity: Servant of the Language, Not Just the Literature

The most theoretically significant characterisation of Shardindu Chaudhary in the special issue is Kalpana Jha's: 'Maithili Sahityak Sewak Nahin, Maithili Bhasak Sewak' — 'Not a servant of Maithili literature, but a servant of the Maithili language.' This distinction is crucial and carefully drawn. A servant of the literature is a writer who produces texts; a servant of the language is

someone for whom the language itself — its survival, health, correctness, and vitality — is the primary concern.

Munni Kamat reinforces this in her essay title 'Bhashavid Shri Shardindu Chaudhary' — 'Linguist Shri Shardindu Chaudhary.' The term bhashavid (literally 'knower of language') positions him in the tradition of Maithili linguistic scholarship — a tradition with deep roots, from Sir George Grierson's systematic documentation of Maithili in the late nineteenth century, through to figures like Dr. Ramamtar Yadav (the subject of Videha's own special issue No. 396), who have devoted their work to understanding the structure, history, and contemporary situation of the language.

This linguistic orientation explains why Shardindu Chaudhary is not easy to categorise as simply a 'writer' in the narrow sense. His concern with language correctness, with the editorial work of Samay-Sal, with facilitating the archiving of other writers' texts — all these activities make sense as expressions of a primary commitment to the language as a living cultural system, not merely as a medium for literary self-expression.

## 4.3 Intellectual Influences and Peer Network

The structure of the Videha 358 special issue reveals something important about Shardindu Chaudhary's place in the Maithili intellectual world: the writers who contribute tributes are themselves significant figures across the full range of contemporary Maithili literature.

Ram Bharos Kapadi 'Bhramar' — whose own prolific output spans drama, fiction, poetry, ghazal, travel writing, and cultural documentation — calls Shardindu Chaudhary the source of his intellectual thirst (Gyan-Pipashak Srot). This is an extraordinary tribute from a major writer: it positions Shardindu Chaudhary not as a peer but as an intellectual formative influence.

Shivshankara Srinivas — born 2 July 1953 in Lohana, Madhubani, and the author of story collections including Trikona, Adahan, Mati, Guna Katha, and Gamak Lok, as well as the critical study Badalait Swar — is a close peer and literary ally. Their relationship is documented in the Videha archive's joint-courtesy arrangement for archiving Srinivas's major works. In The Wire interview (May 2025), Srinivas speaks of how the support of friends and fellow writers was invaluable to his own development — the kind of literary friendship that Shardindu Chaudhary exemplifies.

Ashok (Ashok Kumar Jha, born 18 January 1953) — described by Outlook India (December 2023) as one of the most prominent figures in Maithili

literature, winner of the Yatri Chetna Samman and Kiran Purashkar — contributes the personal essay 'Shardindu Ji.' Ashok's own literary range (fiction, criticism, travel writing, satire, editorship) mirrors the broad scope that characterises Shardindu Chaudhary's activity.

### 4.4 The Interview (Videha 358, pp. 21–25)

The interview conducted by Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil' and published in Videha 358 (pp. 21–25) is the only extended first-person document of Shardindu Chaudhary's voice in the special issue. The interview's presence in the special issue is itself significant: it places Shardindu Chaudhary's own articulations of his literary aims, his understanding of the Maithili situation, and his views on language and culture at the centre of the documentary record.

## 5. Critical Reception: Detailed Analysis of Tribute Essays

### 5.1 Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil' — Three Contributions

Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil' is the most prolific single contributor to the special issue, writing the profile (pp. 15–20), the interview (pp. 21–25), the essay 'Ohina Nahin Tamasait Chhathi Shardindu Chaudhary' (pp. 35–38), and the essay 'Kathya, Tathya Aa Satyak Chintan' (pp. 56–62). The multi-pronged engagement — biographical, conversational, temperamental, and thematic — reflects a close and long-standing relationship with the subject. The essay on 'Kathya, Tathya Aa Satyak Chintan' (Reflection on Content, Fact and Truth) addresses the epistemological dimension of Shardindu Chaudhary's satirical practice: the relationship between the satirist's comic distortion and the underlying reality he is trying to illuminate.

### 5.2 Ram Bharos Kapadi 'Bhramar' — 'The Source of My Intellectual Thirst'

Ram Bharos Kapadi 'Bhramar' is among the most prolific and versatile figures in contemporary Maithili literature. His works archived in the Videha pothi.htm page include: Mahishasur Murdavad evam anya Natak (drama, 1997), Lok Natya: Jat Jatin (folk theatre research, 2007), Huguli upar Bahait Ganga aa an Katha (fiction, 2008), Bhramar Maithili Deergh Kavita (poetry, 2009), Maithili

Lok Sanskriti (Nepali, 2009), Bhaiya Aelai Apan Soraj (drama, 2010), Gharmuha (novel, 2012), Anhariyak Chan (ghazal collection, 2013), China je Ham Dekhal (travel memoir, 2014), Suli par Ijot (drama, 2015), Seema ke Aar-Paar (travel memoir, 2016), Yudhbhumik Esgar Yodha (poetry, 2017), Antivirus (fiction, 2019), Korona ke Santrasm (lockdown diary, 2020), Mithilak Lokjeevan Loksandarbha (2022).

That such a writer calls Shardindu Chaudhary the source of his intellectual thirst ('Hamar Gyan-Pipashak Srot') is one of the most significant testimonies in the special issue. It suggests that Shardindu Chaudhary has functioned as an intellectual catalyst and reference point for a writer whose own work spans an extraordinary range of genres and concerns.

## 5.3 Vibha Rani — 'Serious Attachment to Principles'

Vibha Rani is a major figure in both Maithili and Hindi literature, known for her drama, fiction, and cultural commentary. Her essay 'Shardu Bhaik Gambhir Siddhantapriyata!' focuses on the principled dimension of Shardindu Chaudhary's character. The exclamation mark in the title suggests admiration tinged with affectionate exasperation — the recognition of someone who takes principles seriously even when it might be socially easier not to. This essay positions his intellectual integrity as itself a kind of cultural contribution, modelling a mode of engagement that the Maithili literary world needs.

## 5.4 Dr. Narayanji — 'A Voice of Resistance Against Incongruity'

Dr. Narayanji's essay 'Visangatik Viruddha Pratirodhak-Swar' (A Voice of Resistance Against Incongruity/Absurdity) is the most politically inflected reading in the special issue. The term visangati (incongruity, incoherence, absurdity) points both to the social absurdities that satire targets and to a more systemic condition: the incongruity between professed ideals and actual practice in cultural, institutional, and political life. Shardindu Chaudhary's satirical voice, on this reading, is not merely entertaining but critical and resistant — a counter-voice to the normalisation of absurdity.

## 5.5 Gaurinath — 'The Meaning of Being Shardindu Chaudhary'

Gaurinath's essay 'Shardindu Chaudhary Helak Maane' — 'The Meaning of Being Shardindu Chaudhary' — is the most philosophically ambitious of the tributes. To ask what it means to be a particular person is to ask what values, practices, and relationships constitute that person's existence as a cultural actor.

Gaurinath's essay treats Shardindu Chaudhary as an exemplar — someone whose mode of inhabiting the Maithili literary world is itself a model or lesson for others.

## 5.6 Ashish Anchinhar — 'His Contribution to Maithili Literature'

Ashish Anchinhar — the Maithili poet, ghazal specialist, and literary-historical critic, whose works archived in the Videha pothi.htm include Sandarbha Sahit (ghazal criticism), Preeti Karan Setu Banhal, Setusham: Vibrant Maithili, Maithili Gazalek Vyakaran O Itihas (grammar and history of Maithili ghazal), and Maithili Web Patrakaritaak Itihas (history of Maithili web journalism) — brings a systematising critical perspective to his essay 'Maithili Sahityame Shardindu Chaudhary Ker Yogdan' (pp. 83–87). Anchinhar's expertise in Maithili literary history and genre history gives his assessment of Shardindu Chaudhary's contribution its particular authority.

## 5.7 Shridharam — Vidyapati's Verse as Critical Lens

The essay by Shrivaram applies a verse of Vidyapati — the classical Maithili poet (c. 1350–1435) — as a critical lens: 'Swarth Laagi Karaphu Sab Priti' (All love is for the sake of self-interest). Used ironically, this citation from Maithili's greatest poet suggests that Shardindu Chaudhary's literary practice represents an exception to this cynical observation — a form of love for the language and literature that genuinely transcends self-interest. The use of Vidyapati as a touchstone places Shardindu Chaudhary's work within the long arc of Maithili literary tradition.

## 5.8 Lakshmana Jha Sagar — 'Genuine Maithilist'

Lakshmana Jha Sagar's essay 'Khanti Maithilist Shardu Ji!' uses the term 'Maithilist' — a neologism denoting someone deeply, genuinely and authentically committed to the Maithili language and culture. The qualifier khanti (genuine, authentic, unadulterated) distinguishes this commitment from the performative or opportunistic invocations of Maithili identity that are common in the political and cultural landscape. This essay is, in effect, a certification of authentic commitment.

# 6. Place in the Maithili Literary Tradition

## 6.1 The Satirical-Comic Tradition: Harimohan Jha and Beyond

Maithili's most celebrated comic-satirical writer is Harimohan Jha (1908–1984), variously described as the 'monarch of wit and satire,' 'incarnation of humour,' and 'Vidyapati of Maithili Prose.' His major work Khattar Kakak Tarang — originally published in the periodical Mithila Mihir and later collected — created a new genre: a dialogic satirical form in which the fictional 'uncle' Khattar Kaka systematically dismantles religious and social orthodoxies through comic scriptural exegesis. The stories were added to the Bihar matriculation syllabus in the 1980s, testifying to their canonical status. Jha was awarded the Sahitya Akademi award posthumously in 1985. His novel Kanyadan was translated into English as 'The Bride' in 2022.

Shardindu Chaudhary inherits and extends this tradition. His three satirical collections — Bad Ajagut Dekhal, Goharaganesh, and Kariya Kakkak Coramin — work in the same mode of the sharp-eyed observer of social absurdity, though their targets are the absurdities of contemporary (post-independence, post-globalisation) Mithila rather than specifically religious orthodoxy. The comic tradition in Maithili is not merely entertaining; it has always been a vehicle for social criticism.

## 6.2 The Periodical Tradition

Maithili literary culture has always been inseparable from its periodical culture. As documented in the Videha pothi.htm archive and the 'Ham Mithilawasi' blog, the major journals that shaped modern Maithili writing include: Mithila Mihir (Darbhanga/Patna), Vaidehi (Kashi/Sitamarhi/Darbhanga), Abhivyanjana (Patna/Saharsa), Mithila Darshan, Akhar, Dainik Swadesh, and many others. Harimohan Jha's Khattar Kaka was first published in Mithila Mihir; Rajkamal Chaudhary's first Maithili story was published in Vaidehi (1954).

Shardindu Chaudhary's editorship of Samay-Sal places him squarely in this tradition of editor-writers. The Videha journal itself, launched in 2000/2008 by Gajendra Thakur, is the latest and most extensive expression of this tradition, now operating in the digital medium. His relationship with Videha as a contributor, archive facilitator, and subject of the special issue positions him at the intersection of the older periodical tradition and its contemporary digital continuation.

## 6.3 Memoir and Essayistic Prose

The genre of sansmaran (memoir) in Maithili has not received the same critical attention as fiction or poetry, but it represents a significant tradition of reflective prose. The memoir series Baat-Baat Par Baat and the collection Ja Ham Janitahun both engage with this genre in a comic-satirical mode that is distinctive. The comparison drawn by Gajendra Thakur with Annie Ernaux's Nobel Prize-winning memoir writing — however hyperbolic it might seem from an institutional standpoint — captures something real about the literary mode: that memoir inflected by wit, self-irony, and acute social observation is a demanding literary form.

## 6.4 The Parallel Tradition and Videha

The Videha Maithili Sahitya Aandolan, as described in the Videha archive, positions itself as a 'parallel tradition' (samanantar parampara) to the institutional mainstream represented by the Sahitya Akademi and Maithili Akademi. This parallel tradition values innovation, range, and genuine literary merit over institutional affiliation or caste/political networking. Shardindu Chaudhary's close association with this movement — as contributor, archive facilitator, and the subject of a landmark special issue — marks him as a significant figure within this alternative canon-formation project.

## 6.5 Shivshankar Srinivas: The Archive Connection

The Videha archive's listing of three works by Shivshankar Srinivas — Maithili Upanyasak Aalochana (criticism of the Maithili novel), Chayanit Katha (selected stories), and Mati (Hindi translation by Susmita Pathak) — with the joint courtesy 'Shivshankar Srinivas and Shardindu Chaudhary' is a concrete demonstration of Shardindu Chaudhary's role as cultural custodian. The Videha pothi.htm page contains several cross-references to Shardindu Chaudhary beyond the special issue. Notably, the archive of Shivshankara Srinivas's major critical work Maithili Upanyasak Aalochana is made available with the joint courtesy of Shivshankara Srinivas and Shardindu Chaudhary — indicating his role as a facilitator and co-custodian of Maithili literary archives. Shivshankar Srinivas (born 2 July 1953, Lohana, Madhubani), whose five story collections have been widely acclaimed and whose Maithili Katha Sanchayan (2004) was published by the National Book Trust — the most institutionally prestigious of publishers — is himself a figure of major importance. The archiving of his works with Shardindu Chaudhary's name attached to them suggests a relationship of deep mutual trust and shared commitment to the preservation of

Maithili literary heritage. Ashok's essay-volume and the Kedaranath Chaudhary special issue (Videha 352) also reference him, establishing him as a recurring figure in the critical conversations documented by Videha.

## 7. Thematic Analysis of His Writing

### 7.1 The Absurd as Social Critique

The recurring term ajagut (absurdity, incongruity, something out of place) in the title Bad Ajagut Dekhal signals a philosophical-aesthetic stance: the writer as someone who perceives the distance between the world as it is and the world as it presents itself. This is the fundamental operation of satire. Dr. Narayanji's characterisation of Shardindu Chaudhary as a 'voice of resistance against incongruity' (visangatik viruddha pratirodhak-swar) deepens this: the perception of absurdity is not passive but active, a form of refusal to accept the normalisation of the abnormal.

### 7.2 Language as Political and Cultural Terrain

Kalpana Jha's framing of him as a servant of the language rather than the literature points to a dimension of his work that goes beyond aesthetics into cultural politics. Maithili, as one of the languages in the Eighth Schedule of the Indian Constitution and the language of a population estimated at 30–50 million, faces ongoing pressures from Hindi and English. The commitment to linguistic correctness, to the health of Maithili usage, and to the preservation of the language's distinctive vocabulary and grammar is, in this context, a political act as well as a scholarly one.

This orientation connects Shardindu Chaudhary to the broader Maithili language movement — the decades-long campaign for constitutional recognition (achieved in 2003), for official use of Maithili in Bihar administration, and for Maithili-medium education. His work as editor and linguist is inseparable from this political-cultural context.

### 7.3 Self and Society: The Comic-Autobiographical Mode

The memoir series Baat-Baat Par Baat and the collection Ja ham Janitahun represent a sustained engagement with the autobiographical mode inflected through comic irony. The use of satire within personal memoir creates a double perspective — the self as both subject and satirical object.

The memoir series and Ja Ham Janitahun both deploy the comic-autobiographical mode — the genre in which the writer turns the satirical eye on their own life and experience. This is a difficult mode to execute well: it requires simultaneously inhabiting the narrator's perspective and maintaining enough critical distance to see that perspective's limitations and absurdities. The title Ja Ham Janitahun — 'Had I known...' — is a perfect emblem of this mode: the retrospective wisdom that arrives too late, and whose belated arrival is itself comic.

### 7.4 Memory, Community and Cultural Transmission

The four-volume Baat-Baat Par Baat, as an extended memoir-essay series, is also a work of cultural memory. It documents a world — the Maithili literary world of the late twentieth and early twenty-first century — through the accumulated details of personal experience, literary friendship, intellectual debate, and cultural occasion. In this respect it performs a function analogous to the oral tradition of katha (storytelling) in Maithili culture: the preservation and transmission of a community's experience through the medium of language.

### 7.5 Cultural Integrity and Principled Commitment

Multiple contributors note his resistance to compromise on matters of principle — whether in language use, editorial standards, or cultural positioning. Vibha Rani's essay on his 'Gambhir Siddhantapriyata' (serious attachment to principles) and the characterization by Shivshankara Srinivas as 'as sweet as he is resolute' together point to a writer for whom integrity is both a personal and a literary value.

## 8. Overall Significance

Shardindu Chaudhary's significance in contemporary Maithili culture operates at several interrelated levels:

- As a satirist, he extends and renews the great tradition of Maithili comic-critical prose, descending from Harimohan Jha through to his own generation, giving it contemporary social targets and a distinctive personal voice.
- As a memoirist, his multi-volume Baat-Baat Par Baat and the collection Ja Ham Janitahun constitute a substantial and distinctive body of reflective

prose that merits comparison with the best in Indian-language memoir writing.

- As an editor of Samay-Sal, his editorial vision and the editorials he wrote represent an intellectual contribution to Maithili periodical culture whose significance has been articulated by Ajit Kumar Jha in Videha 358.
- As a linguist and language activist, his primary commitment to the health and survival of the Maithili language (not just its literature) situates him in a distinguished tradition of Maithili language scholarship and cultural activism.
- As a mentor and intellectual presence, his influence on younger and contemporary writers — documented across numerous essays in the special issue —As a mentor and interlocutor, his influence on younger Maithili writers — documented in the warm personal essays by Kedar Kanan, Ashok, and others in the special issue represents a form of cultural transmission and community-building that is irreplaceable.
- As an archive facilitator, his role in enabling the preservation and dissemination of other writers' works (most concretely in the case of Shivshankar Srinivas's three archived works) ensures the continuity of Maithili literary heritage.
- As the subject of Videha 358, his recognition by the Maithili literary community through one of the most significant parallel-tradition platforms in the language is itself a cultural-historical fact of importance.

The editor of Videha articulates the significance of the special issue itself: in the Maithili world, recognition by living peers and by a committed readership is, in many ways, more meaningful than institutional awards. The fact that Videha readers responded with such enthusiasm to this issue suggests that Shardindu Chaudhary's contribution is genuinely felt, not merely acknowledged it reflects something real about the relative values at play in contemporary Maithili literary culture: that authentic community recognition, rooted in actual engagement with the work, carries a weight that formal institutional prizes sometimes cannot match.

## 9. Associated Figures: The Literary World of Shardindu Chaudhary

Understanding Shardindu Chaudhary requires understanding the literary world he inhabits. The following figures appear across the Videha archive and are

connected to him either as contributors to his special issue or as literary peers whose works are archived in close association with his.

## 9.1 Writers Who Contributed to Videha 358

- Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil' — profile writer, interviewer, essayist; one of the most versatile figures in contemporary Maithili non-fiction.
- Kalpana Jha — essayist; also known for translations (Shephalika Varma's Yayavari into Hindi) and collection of folk songs. Her works (Gosaunik Geet, Nashamukti Git, Niniya) are archived in Videha pothi.htm.
- Ram Bharos Kapadi 'Bhramar' — arguably the most prolific living Maithili writer across genres; his 15+ books span drama, fiction, poetry, ghazal, travel writing, and folk culture documentation. All archived in Videha pothi.htm.
- Vibha Rani — prominent Maithili/Hindi dramatist and fiction writer; two plays archived in Videha pothi.htm.
- Dr. Narayanji — poet and essayist; author of Digantse Uthait Lahari (poetry) and Sanjhbati (fiction), archived in Videha pothi.htm.
- Munni Kamat — poet and essayist; author of Sukhal Mon Tarsal Aankhi (poetry/prose), Antatah, Chukka (children's stories), and Matik Suwas (novel), archived in Videha pothi.htm.
- Gaurinath — essayist and cultural commentator.
- Ajit Kumar Jha — author of Jatbe Bujhalahu Tatbe Likhalaahu (archived in Videha); essayist and literary critic.
- Ashok (Ashok Kumar Jha, born 1953, Lohna Tol, Madhubani) — winner of Yatri Chetna Samman and Kiran Purashkar; author of Chakravyuh, Ohi Raatik Bhor, Maatbar, Daddy Gaam, and critical works; all archived in Videha pothi.htm. Profiled in Outlook India (December 2023).
- Shivshankara Srinivas (born 1953, Lohana, Madhubani) — author of Trikona, Adahan, Mati, Guna Katha, Gamak Lok; critical study Badalait Swar; editor of Maithili Katha Sanchayan (National Book Trust, 2004). Profiled in The Wire (May 2025) and Scroll.in (September 2024).
- Kedar Kanan — poet and editor; his name appears across multiple Videha issues.
- Ashish Anchinhar — ghazal poet, literary historian; extensive archive in Videha pothi.htm including Maithili Gazalek Vyakaran O Itihas and Maithili Web Patrakaritaak Itihas.

- Gajendra Thakur — editor of Videha; novelist and critic; author of Sahasrabadhani, Sahasrashirsha and other works archived in Videha pothi.htm.
- Lakshmana Jha Sagar — poet and essayist.
- Jagadananda Jha 'Manu' — fiction writer; his works appear in multiple Videha issues.
- Shridharam — critic and essayist.

## 10. The Maithili Literary Context: A Brief Orientation

Shardindu Chaudhary's work can only be fully understood against the backdrop of Maithili literary history and the contemporary situation of the language. The following orientation draws on the Videha archive, the 'Ham Mithilawasi' blog, the Darbhanga Tower blog, and the IJCRT academic survey.

### 10.1 Maithili Language and Its Status

Maithili is the classical literary language of the Mithila region — comprising major districts of north Bihar (Darbhanga, Madhubani, Saharsa, Supaul, Muzzafarpur, Sitamarhi, Purnia) and parts of Jharkhand and Nepal's Terai. With an estimated 30–50 million speakers, it is among the largest Indian languages without a separate state. It was added to the Eighth Schedule of the Indian Constitution in 2003, giving it official recognition — a long-sought achievement of the Maithili language movement. Its script, Tirhuta (Mithilakshara), is of great antiquity; Google's Noto Fonts project has provided open-source digital fonts for Tirhuta, Kaithi, and Newari, all linked from the Videha pothi.htm.

### 10.2 The Satirical Tradition: Harimohan Jha

Harimohan Jha (1908–1984) is the towering figure of Maithili comic writing. Born in Vaishali, Bihar, and a professor of Philosophy at Patna University, he innovated the form of Khattar Kakak Tarang — a dialogic satirical genre in which the fictional uncle Khattar Kaka, 'enjoying himself after a drink of badam thandai,' dismantles religious and social orthodoxies through comic scriptural exegesis. As the Darbhanga Tower blog records, Jha was hailed as

'monarch of wit and satire,' 'incarnation of humour,' and 'Vidyapati of Maithili Prose.' He was awarded the Sahitya Akademi award posthumously in 1985.

## 10.3 The 21st Century: A Golden Age of Maithili Short Fiction

The IJCRT academic survey (Bijayendra Jha, October 2025) documents that more than 300 Maithili short story collections have been published in the last two and a half decades. Seven have received Sahitya Akademi awards: Nirja Renu's Ritambhara (2003), Vibhuti Anand's Kath (2006), Pradeep Bihari's Sarokar (2007), Manmohan Jha's Gangaputra (2009), Prof. Manmohan Jha's Khisa (2015), Shyam Darihare's Badki Kaki Eta Haat Mail Dat Com (2016), and Prof. Veena Thakur's Parineeta (2018). Shardindu Chaudhary's Kariya Kakkak Coramin (2016) is listed in this survey alongside these award-winning collections, situating him within this flourishing contemporary moment.

### Relationship with Maithili Fiction and Short Stories

Academic scholarship (IJCRT, 2025, 'A Critical Analysis of Maithili Short Stories: Twenty First Century') places Shardindu Chaudhary's short story 'Kariya Kakkak Coramin' (2016) among the significant contributions to twenty-first century Maithili fiction. This scholarly recognition situates him not merely as a humorist but as a contributor to the more formal tradition of Maithili katha (short story) alongside Sahitya Akademi-awarded writers.

## 10.4 Periodical Culture and Literary Formation

The Maithili literary world has always been sustained by its periodical culture. Major journals include Mithila Mihir (Darbhanga/Patna), Vaidehi (Kashi/Sitamarhi/Darbhanga), Abhivyanjana (Patna/Saharsa), and now Videha (www.videha.co.in, since 2000/2008). Samay-Sal, which Shardindu Chaudhary edited, belongs to this tradition of literary periodicals that shape taste, form intellectual community, and carry the ongoing conversation of Maithili letters.

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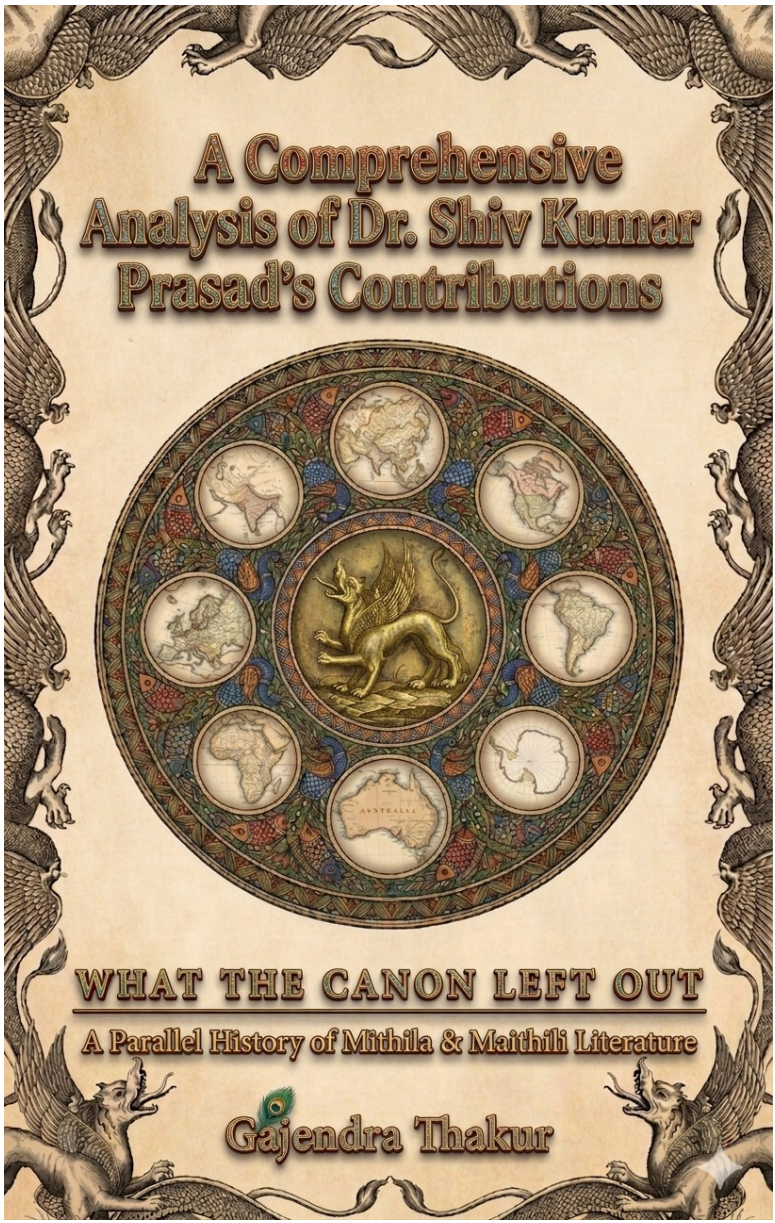
**LESSON 082 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**



# CRITICAL APPRECIATION

*of*

**Dr. Shiv Kumar Prasad**

**डॉ. शिव कुमार प्रसाद**

*Poet · Short Story Writer · Literary Critic · Translator*

*Through Indian Kavyashastra | Western Literary Theory | Videha Parallel History Framework | Navya-Nyāya Epistemology*

## Preface: Three Frameworks, One Lens

This critical appreciation applies three distinct but interlocking methodological frameworks to the literary work of Dr. Shiv Kumar Prasad as documented across the Videha archives (Issues 1–438, www.videha.co.in):

First, Indian Kavyashastra and Western literary theory — the classical and modern critical traditions that furnish the primary analytical vocabulary. Second, the Videha Parallel History Framework (समानान्तर इतिहास — Samaantar Itihaas), the explicitly multi-lens methodology developed and practised by Videha editor Gajendra Thakur, which applies seven simultaneous critical lenses — Marxism, historical materialism, structuralism, magic realism, postmodernism, feminism, and deconstruction — alongside Indian aesthetic theory to any literary text. Third, Navya-Nyāya (नव्य न्याय), the rigorous Sanskrit epistemological system developed by Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya in his Tattvacintāmaṇi (c. 1325 CE) and elaborated by Raghunātha Śiromaṇi, Gadādhara Bhaṭṭācārya, and others — applied here not merely as a logical system but as a hermeneutic: a method for achieving pravāha-pratyakṣa (flowing, transparent cognition) of a literary object through the precise identification of pakṣa (subject-proposition), hetu (logical reason), sādhya (what is to be established), and vyāpti (the pervasive invariant relation between two properties).

The Videha Parallel History Framework is explicitly documented in the Videha archive itself: editor Gajendra Thakur's study of the poet Buch Ji in Videha Sadeha 33 (Issues 1–350) applies Marxist, historical, structuralist, magic-

realist, postmodern, feminist, and deconstructive lenses alongside Indian aesthetics — a methodology this appreciation now applies to Dr. Shiv Kumar Prasad.

# I. Biographical and Contextual Location

## 1.1 Identity and Institutional Position:The Voice from Mithila

Dr. Shiv Kumar Prasad (डॉ. शिव कुमार प्रसाद) is a significant contemporary Maithili literary figure who has made enduring contributions as a poet, short story writer, literary critic, and translator. He served as an Assistant Professor (Selection Grade) in the Hindi Department at Hariprashad Sah Mahavidyalaya (Nirmali College), Nirmali, Supaul — a region in the heart of Mithilanchal, Bihar. His rootedness in this geography — the land of the Kosi river, of traditional Maithil culture, and of a vibrant folk heritage — forms the bedrock of his literary imagination.

Dr. Prasad's creative output spans poetry (kavita), short fiction (beehan katha), critical essays (samalochna), and translation. His work has been published extensively in Videha — the first Maithili fortnightly e-journal (www.videha.co.in), edited by Gajendra Thakur, which stands as the premier digital platform for Maithili literature globally. Over the span of nearly three decades of Videha's publication history (Issues 1–438), his contributions appear consistently, establishing him as a respected and prolific voice.

His literary identity is shaped by two intersecting concerns: the preservation and enrichment of Maithili language and culture, and the critical engagement with social realities — caste, poverty, urbanisation, and the erosion of traditional human bonds. This tension between rootedness and critique makes his work particularly resonant.

He is simultaneously a creative writer in Maithili, a literary critic, and a public intellectual who has participated in the institutional life of Maithili literature through Sagar Raati Deep Jarai all-night storytelling marathons, book-release ceremonies, and academic seminars. His academic appointment is in Hindi — the regional prestige language — while his primary creative and critical medium is Maithili, the language of his cultural habitus. This bilingual professional identity is itself a micro-instance of the macro-political contest between Maithili and Hindi that Videha as a whole documents.

### 1.2 The Videha Context

Videha — Pratham Maithili Paksik E-Patrika (ISSN 2229-547X), founded 1 January 2008 (building on the Bhaalsarik Gaachh blog from 2004), is the first Maithili fortnightly e-journal. It began as what is now recognised as Maithili's oldest internet presence. Edited by Gajendra Thakur, Videha has published 438+ issues through April 2026. Dr. Prasad has been a contributor across multiple decades of this archive, appearing in issues as early as Issue 14 and continuing through Issue 37 and the broader 438-issue run. His work is included in the Videha-Sadeha print anthologies (Shruti Prakashan, Delhi).

> *भाषा साहित्य तँ झड़-झड़ बहैत झड़ना थिक। साहित्यक धार होइत अछि जे मात्र अपन किनछैरेटा मे नहि*
>
> *वरन् किनछैरक संग-संग अपन बान्हकेँ तोड़ैत केतौ-सँ-केतौ धरि हृदय रूपी भूलोककेँ आप्लावित कऽ दैत अछि।*

*— Dr. Shiv Kumar Prasad, 'Maithili: Sarkaar aur Ham Sabh' (Videha)*

(Literature and language are like a ceaselessly falling waterfall: literature has a current that does not merely flow within its banks but breaks its boundaries and, alongside those banks, inundates the earth-like heart all the way to every shore.)

## II. Primary Texts: A Documented Catalogue

The following works by Dr. Prasad are documented in the Videha archives:

***Poetry (Kavita)***

Khebaiyan (खेबैया); Maay Hamar Nav Kumbh Naheli (माय हमर नव कुम्भ नहेली); Dekh Elaun Ham Patna (देख एलौं हम पटना); Shahar O Gel (शहर ओ गेल); Bauwa Ker Ubtan (बौआ केर उबटन) — Videha Issue 14, pp. 695–704. Nirmaliki Nirmalatama (निर्मलीक निर्मलतामे); Tain Kichhu Ne Kichhu Likhait Jaau (तैं किछु ने किछु लिखैत जाउ) — Videha Issue 17, pp. 1163–1172. Extensive collection of original poems — Videha Issue 21, pp. 1001–1071. Additional poems across Issues 16, 17.

***Short Fiction (Beehan Katha / Laghu Katha)***

Aanhar (आन्हर — Blind); Banmaanush aur Jamila (बनमानुष आ जमीला) — Videha Issue 17, pp. 686–704. Four beehan katha — Videha Issue 24 (Prelim 24), pp. 578–581. Story 'Adiya' (अदिया) embedded in critical writing — Videha Issue 16. Oral presentations of 'Aanhar' and 'Banmaanush aur Manush' at Sagar Raati Deep Jarai gatherings, Devghar and Nirmali.

***Literary Criticism (Samalochna)***

'Sakhaaree-Petaaree Ker Taani-Bharni' — extended review of Nand Vilas Rai's katha sangrah — Videha Issue 16, pp. 196–210. 'Dalit Sahityaken Aana Sahityas Futkaibak Prayojan' (दलित साहित्यकेँ आन साहित्यसँ फुटकेबाक प्रयोजन) — Videha Issue 20, pp. 455–459.

***Translation (Anuvaad)***

Maithili translation of Rajni Chhabra's Hindi poetry collection Pighalte Himkhand (पिघलते हिमखण्ड) — Videha Issue 21, pp. 912–1000.

***Institutional Roles***

Presiding member (Adhyaksha Mandal) and story-reviewer at Sagar Raati Deep Jarai gatherings — Nirmali (87th session, 19 Sept 2015), Bermo, and Devghar sessions. Book-release ceremonies (pothe lokarpan). Speaker at 'Maithili: Sarkaar aur Ham Sabh' seminar. Member of Mithilanchal Vikas Parishad activities.

# III. Analysis Through Indian Kavyashastra

### 3.1 *Rasa Siddhanta (Theory of Aesthetic Emotion)*

## Bharatamuni and Abhinavagupta

The Natyashastra of Bharatamuni (c. 2nd cent. BCE–4th cent. CE) establishes the doctrine of rasa — the aesthetic emotion that arises in the sensitive spectator/reader (sahridaya) when the vibhava (excitant), anubhava (consequent expression), and vyabhichari bhava (transient moods) combine to evoke the sthayibhava (permanent emotion). Abhinavagupta's Abhinavabharati (c. 1000 CE) universalises this into a theory of aesthetic experience as a form of self-recognition (pratibha).The Natyashastra of Bharatamuni and its

subsequent elaboration by Abhinavagupta in the Abhinavabharati identifies eight (later nine) primary rasas. Dr. Prasad's poetry engages most deeply with:

***Karuna Rasa (करुण रस) in Khebaiyan***

Khebaiyan (The Boatman) is a sustained evocation of karuna — the pathos of those left without means of crossing. The vibhava is social abandonment: neither money, nor political connections, nor hereditary prestige will summon a boatman for the speaker. The anubhava is the refrain — 'binu khebaiyan hamare naav achi' (our boat is without a boatman) — which, through its iterative structure, accumulates the anubhava of quiet, dignified lament. Abhinavagupta's concept of camatkara — the sudden flash of aesthetic delight-in-recognition — operates here through the refrain's transformation: what begins as a complaint gradually reveals itself as a statement of radical self-possession.

> *सबहक नाॅकेँ भेटल खेबैया / बिनु खेबैया हमरे नाॅ अछि*
>
> *देखू पार आब केना लगैत अछि / बिनु खेबैया हमरे नाॅ अछि।*

*— Dr. Shiv Kumar Prasad, 'Khebaiyan', Videha Issue 14, p. 695*

(Everyone's boat has found a boatman / only our boat is without one / see now how the crossing seems / our boat is without a boatman.)

Poems like Khebaiyan and Maay Hamar Nav Kumbh Naheli are saturated with a deep, aching compassion. In Khebaiyan, the speaker searches for a boatman (metaphorically, a guide, a leader, a patron) who will help cross the river of life — and finds none. The social loneliness of the marginalised — those without money, caste connections, or political influence — is rendered with quiet, devastating pathos.

***Shanta Rasa and Bhakti Aesthetics in Maay Hamar Nav Kumbh Naheli***

The poem on the mother achieves shanta rasa — the peace of settled spiritual insight — through a systematic stripping away of conventional claims to worth. The mother is 'na vidushi na sunnari' (neither learned nor beautiful), yet she is 'nav kumbh naheli' (freshly bathed at the Kumbh, i.e., pure). This is the Bhakti aesthetic of antara-shuddhata (inner purity as the highest value), echoing Kabir's nirguṇa devotionalism and the Vaishnava understanding that the divine dwells in simplicity, not ornament. Serenity/Spiritual Calm): The poem on the mother — Maay Hamar Nav Kumbh Naheli — achieves a remarkable spiritual serenity. The mother, who is neither learned nor beautiful, yet pure like the

Kumbh bath, embodies the ideal of selfless karma-yoga. This recalls the Bhakti aesthetic of inner purity over outward show.

***Viyoga Shringara in Shahar O Gel***

The poem 'Shahar O Gel' (The City He Went To) is structured as a viyoga poem — the pathos of separation — in which the object of loss is not a beloved but a community. The 'he' who went to the city to become human was already human in the village; the irony (vyangya) embedded in the vibhava — that urbanisation promises humanisation but delivers petrification ('pathara gael') — generates a bitter viyoga shringara that resonates with the classical formula of the Barahmasa (twelve-month separation songs) while pointing toward contemporary social critique.

Shahar O Gel (The City He Went To) is a classic viyoga poem — the lament of the village left behind, of human bonds dissolving in the stone jungle of the city. The vibhava (excitant) is urbanisation; the anubhava (consequent) is the severing of community ties.

> *"शहर ओ गेल मनुक्ख बनै लेल / गाममे रहि बन-मानुख छल / शहरक पाथर केर जंगलमे / सभकेँ सभ आइ पथरा गेल।"*
>
> *— Dr. Shiv Kumar Prasad, 'Shahar O Gel' (Videha, Issue 14)*

(He went to the city to become human / in the village, he was a jungle creature / in the stone jungle of the city / everyone has turned to stone today.)

### 3.2 *Dhvani Siddhanta (Theory of Suggestion / Resonance)*

## — Anandavardhana

Anandavardhana's Dhvanyaloka (9th cent. CE) establishes dhvani — the resonant, suggested meaning (vyangya) beyond the literal (vacya) — as the soul (atma) of poetry. His taxonomy identifies vivaksita-anyaparavacya dhvani as the highest form: where the primary meaning is fully intended but retreats behind the luminous suggested meaning.

In Khebaiyan, the 'boatman' (khebaiyan) and 'boat' (naav) operate as pure dhvani-vehicles. The suggested meanings stratify: the boat is the Maithili language itself, adrift without institutional support; it is the community of the dispossessed; it is the speaker's literary career navigating a patronage-starved culture. The literal ferryman recedes completely. This is dhvani of the highest order. Anandavardhana would classify this as pure suggestion (shuddha

dhvani), where 'the suggested completely outshines the expressed.' Anandavardhana's Dhvanyaloka establishes dhvani — the suggestive resonance beyond literal meaning — as the soul (atma) of poetry. Dr. Prasad's verse is rich in dhvani. In Khebaiyan, the 'boatman' (khebaiyan) is a multi-layered symbol: it suggests at once a literal ferryman, a political leader, a social patron, and even divine grace. The refrain — 'binu khebaiyan hamare naav achi' (our boat is without a boatman) — acquires the resonance of an entire community's disenfranchisement. This is precisely what Anandavardhana calls vivaksita-anyaparavacya dhvani — where the primary meaning recedes to make way for a more potent suggested meaning.

In the Dalit literature essay, dhvani operates differently — as argumentative understatement (arthaantara-nyasa). When Dr. Prasad writes 'Sahitya rajniti nai chhai' (Literature is not politics), the suggested meaning is more capacious than the explicit claim: it implies a critique of the instrumentalisation of art by any ideological programme, a point too radical to state directly in the contentious Maithili literary-political context of the 2010s.

**3.3** ***Vakrokti Siddhanta (Theory of Oblique Expression)***

## Vakrokti Siddhanta — Kuntaka

Kuntaka's Vakroktijivita (c. 950 CE) locates the animating principle of poetry in vakrokti — the artistically oblique, deviant, non-prosaic expression that makes language poetic. Kuntaka identifies six types of vakrata (obliqueness): at the level of individual letter, word, compound, sentence, pericope, and overall composition.

Dr. Prasad's critical essay on Sakhaaree-Petaaree is itself a demonstration of vakrokti at the compositional level (prasanga-vakrata). He employs the extended metaphor of literally 'opening' a sakhaaree-petaaree (traditional Maithil bridal box): 'Sakhaaree khuli gael. Dekhu ketnek neek baus chhai ime.' (The sakhaaree opened. Look how good the fragrance/composition within it is.) — before proceeding to analyse the collection. This compositional device transforms the entire critical essay into a performed cultural ritual, producing a meaning that transcends the sum of its analytical parts.

Kuntaka's Vakroktijivita celebrates the oblique, the artistic deviation from the expected expression (svabhavokti). Dr. Prasad's social commentary is consistently vakra — it never preaches directly. The poem on urbanisation does not lecture; it presents the stone turning to stone (pathara gael). His critical essay on Dalit literature, too, employs vakrokti when it wryly notes that

dividing literature by caste is like dividing a river by its banks — the water flows anyway.

**3.4** ***Auchitya Siddhanta (Theory of Propriety)***

## Auchitya Siddhanta — Kshemendra

Kshemendra's Auchityavichara-charcha (c. 11th cent.) identifies auchitya (propriety) — the apt fit of word, form, and content — as the supreme virtue of poetry. He argues that even a single violation of auchitya poisons an otherwise excellent composition.

Dr. Prasad's own critical practice is explicitly auchitya-oriented. In his review of Sakhaaree-Petaaree, he specifically identifies violations of auchitya — the inappropriate use of Hindi and Urdu words ('dil', 'maalum', 'mehsoos') in what should be a purely Maithili register — as weaknesses in an otherwise strong collection. This is a direct application of Kshemendra's doctrine. His own poetry maintains auchitya through consistent deployment of Maithili folk idiom, regional imagery (the Nirmali landscape, the Kosi plain, the sakhaaree-petaaree), and verse forms that echo the Maithili geet tradition.

Kshemendra's Auchityavichara-charcha holds that propriety — the apt matching of form, language, and content — is the highest poetic virtue. Dr. Prasad's use of Maithili's folk idiom, its colloquialisms, its regional imagery (the sakhaaree-petaaree, the nirmali, the kosi), demonstrates a consistent auchitya. The poem Dekh Elaun Ham Patna uses the colloquial language of a Maithil villager's first encounter with the city — phonetically and syntactically faithful to the rural register — ensuring that the poem never loses contact with its lived referent.

## 3.5 Alankara Shastra — Vamana and Mammata

Vamana's Kavyalankarasutravritta (c. 8th cent.) identifies guna (qualities) and dosha (defects) as the primary evaluative categories. Mammata's Kavyaprakasha (c. 11th cent.) synthesises the alankara, rasa, and dhvani traditions into a comprehensive poetics.

In Dr. Prasad's poetry, the most frequently operative alankara (figure of speech) is rupaka (complete metaphor / identification) — not mere upama (simile). In 'Maay Hamar Nav Kumbh Naheli', the mother IS the Kumbh bath (nav kumbh naheli): not merely like it, but identified with it. This is rupaka of the highest order, achieving the total fusion of tenor and vehicle that Mammata regards as

the supreme achievement of metaphor. The poem 'Bauwa Ker Ubtan' (Child's Unguent) similarly employs rupaka to identify the child's innocence with the purifying unguent used in wedding rituals.

# IV. Analysis Through Western Literary Criticism

## 4.1 New Criticism: Organic Unity and the Well-Wrought Urn

The New Critics — Cleanth Brooks (The Well Wrought Urn, 1947), Robert Penn Warren, John Crowe Ransom, I.A. Richards — privileged the poem as an autonomous verbal object governed by tension, paradox, irony, and ambiguity. The New Critics privileged the text as an autonomous object, analysing its internal tensions, paradoxes, and irony.

Khebaiyan exemplifies the 'well-wrought urn': its structural irony is that a complaint about lack — the absence of a boatman — accumulates, through sheer repetition, into an act of dignified assertion. Brooks would identify this as the poem's 'paradox': the poem's apparent passivity ('we have no boatman') is its deepest form of agency — the act of naming the injustice constitutes the crossing. The refrain does not weaken through repetition; it intensifies, demonstrating what Richards called 'the interinanimation of words' — each recurrence charges the previous with new semantic weight.

***New Criticism: Close Reading & Tension***

Dr. Prasad's Khebaiyan exemplifies what Brooks called the 'well-wrought urn': a poem whose meaning is inseparable from its form. The refrain 'binu khebaiyan hamare naav achi' creates a structural irony — it is a statement of lack that, by its very repetition, accumulates emotional mass and becomes a statement of dignity. The paradox of the marginalised asserting themselves through a complaint is quintessentially New Critical irony.

## 4.2 *Marxist Literary Criticism: Literature as Social Praxis*

### Marxist Aesthetics: Lukács, Eagleton, Williams

Georg Lukács' theory of 'critical realism' (Studies in European Realism, 1950) distinguishes realism — the faithful representation of social totality and its

contradictions — from naturalism (surface accumulation) and modernist fragmentation. Terry Eagleton (Marxism and Literary Criticism, 1976) emphasises literature's ideological encoding and decoding. Raymond Williams' concept of 'structures of feeling' (Marxism and Literature, 1977) identifies the lived, experiential texture of a historical moment that art uniquely preserves.

From the perspective of Marxist aesthetics — as articulated by Georg Lukács, Terry Eagleton, and Raymond Williams — literature is not merely a reflection of material conditions but an active site of ideological struggle. Dr. Prasad's poetry is deeply engaged with what Lukács called 'critical realism': the faithful, living representation of social contradictions. In Shahar O Gel, the village-city binary is not a nostalgic pastoral; it is a sharp critique of capitalist urbanisation's dehumanising effect on communities rooted in non-monetary bonds of kinship. His critical essay on Dalit literature explicitly interrogates the political economy of language and canon-formation.

Dr. Prasad's 'Shahar O Gel' is a Lukácsian critical-realist poem. The village-city binary is not nostalgic pastoral; it is a representation of capitalism's specific mode of destroying non-commodified social relations. The poem's images — 'patthar ke jungle' (stone jungle), 'rishta-naata sab matiya-met bhagel' (all kinship relations levelled to dust) — are what Lukács would call 'intensive typicality': individual images that crystallise a social totality. Williams would recognise in this poem a 'structure of feeling' — the specific texture of what it is to be a Maithili villager who has watched a family member absorbed into urban anonymity.

Dr. Prasad's essay on Dalit literature is simultaneously a Marxist text. His argument that literature cannot be partitioned by caste without dying is a materialist argument about the conditions of literary production: the fragmentation of readership and authorial community into caste ghettoes mirrors the fragmentation of the working class in capitalist economies, which serves the interests of dominant groups. Eagleton would read the demand to separate 'Dalit literature' as an ideological move that, despite its progressive intentions, replicates rather than transcends the caste structure.

## 4.3 Structuralism and Semiotics: Saussure, Barthes, Jakobson

Ferdinand de Saussure's distinction between langue (language system) and parole (individual utterance) is foundational. Roland Barthes' S/Z (1970) analyses narrative as a system of codes. Roman Jakobson's theory of the poetic function — the orientation of the message toward itself — illuminates Dr. Prasad's verse technique.

Jakobson's 'poetic function' — the projection of the principle of equivalence from the axis of selection onto the axis of combination — is visibly operative in Khebaiyan's refrain structure. The equivalences established between 'kinako taka par lagauatanh' (money crosses them), 'kinako neta par lagauatanh' (a leader crosses them), and 'apan-apan baans bhiraune' (each leans on their own bamboo pole) create a paradigmatic axis of privilege that the poem's syntagmatic movement, ending always on the speaker's boatless boat, systematically excludes. The refrain is Jakobson's 'return of the same differently charged' — the hallmark of the poetic function.

Barthes' distinction between 'readerly' (lisible) and 'writerly' (scriptible) texts is instructive for Dr. Prasad's criticism. His essay on Sakhaaree-Petaaree is a 'writerly' critical act — it productively rewrites the collection through the metaphor of opening a bridal box, generating new meanings that supplement and transform the original texts.

## 4.4 Postcolonial Theory: Spivak, Bhabha, Said

***Postcolonial Criticism: Subaltern Voices***

Homi Bhabha, Gayatri Spivak, and Frantz Fanon have theorised the literature of the colonised and the marginalised as a site of counter-narrative. Dr. Prasad's work operates within what Spivak would call the 'subaltern cartography' of Maithili. By writing in Maithili — a language that has long struggled for institutional recognition despite its ancient literary heritage — he is making an explicitly postcolonial choice. His poems do not translate a Maithil experience into Hindi (the dominant language of the region's public sphere) but insist on the untranslatability and the irreducibility of that experience in its own tongue.

Gayatri Spivak's 'Can the Subaltern Speak?' (1988), Edward Said's Orientalism (1978), and Homi Bhabha's The Location of Culture (1994) theorise the epistemological violence of colonial and neo-colonial representation and the strategies of counter-representation available to marginalised subjects.

Dr. Prasad's choice of Maithili as his primary creative medium is a postcolonial act in the specific sense Spivak identifies: the refusal to speak in the coloniser's language (here, Hindi as administrative and cultural hegemon) is not silence but the production of an alternative discourse that cannot be assimilated into the dominant framework without distortion. Bhabha's concept of 'hybridity' — the productive ambivalence of the colonised subject who inhabits both languages and cultures — is embodied in Dr. Prasad's professional bilingualism: teaching in Hindi, writing in Maithili, negotiating the gap between the two daily.

Said's analysis of 'Orientalism' is relevant in an inverted form: Dr. Prasad's criticism resists what might be called 'intra-Indian Orientalism' — the Hindi-centric literary establishment's tendency to read Maithili as archaic, provincial, or merely 'folk', rather than as a sophisticated literary culture with its own classical tradition rooted in Vidyapati and the ancient Mithila philosophical schools.

***Phenomenological Criticism: The Poetics of Lived Experience***

Martin Heidegger's analysis of poetry as the 'clearing of Being' and Gaston Bachelard's phenomenology of poetic space offer illuminating lenses for Dr. Prasad's maternal poems. In Maay Hamar Nav Kumbh Naheli, the mother is not represented through psychological realism but through a phenomenological essence — she is purity, she is the ritual bath, she is the organic fabric of home. Bachelard's 'poetics of space' would identify the poem as an evocation of the primordial 'nest' of belonging, where the mother's body is the first and final dwelling-place.

## 4.5 Feminist Criticism and Gender Theory

The poems 'Maay Hamar Nav Kumbh Naheli' and 'Bauwa Ker Ubtan', along with the story 'Jamila', engage directly with the representation of women in Mithili society. From a feminist critical perspective — informed by Elaine Showalter's gynocriticism, Julia Kristeva's semanalysis, and Adrienne Rich's poetics of the 'coming out' of marginalised experience — these texts are productively ambivalent.

The maternal poem, on one reading, risks reinstating the ideological equation of womanhood with selfless service: the mother's virtue lies precisely in her abnegation of ornament, desire, and self-interest. Kristeva's 'maternal semiotic' — the pre-Oedipal, rhythmic, bodily dimension of language that poetry uniquely recuperates — is evident in the poem's incantatory quality; but the poem simultaneously reproduces the patriarchal ideal of the 'good mother'. The story 'Jamila', however, suggests a more critical gender consciousness: the name itself (Arabic-Maithili contact zone) signals a concern with the woman at the intersection of multiple marginalising identities.

### 4.6 Deconstruction: Derrida

Jacques Derrida's deconstructive reading practice — the identification of the 'trace', the supplement, the différance that destabilises any text's claim to unified, self-present meaning — applies to Dr. Prasad's most apparently stable text: the essay on Dalit literature.

The essay's central claim — 'literature is not politics; when politics enters literature, literature dies' — deconstructs itself. For the essay is itself a political act: the defence of literary universalism against caste-based fragmentation is a political position, shaped by a specific ideological location (that of a Hindi-department professor whose institutional identity bridges caste communities). Derrida's 'supplement' is visible: the essay supplements the Maithili literary canon by speaking for those whose work has been excluded from the Dalit literature list (Lallit, Manipada, Gajendra Thakur's Sahastrasirsha) — but in doing so, it tacitly reinforces the boundary between 'high' Maithili literature and 'Dalit' Maithili literature that it claims to dissolve.

## V. The Videha Parallel History Framework (समानान्तर इतिहास)

The Videha Parallel History Framework is the critical methodology developed by Gajendra Thakur across the Videha archive — most explicitly demonstrated in his multi-lens study of the poet Buch Ji (Vaidyanath Mishra 'Yatri') in Videha Sadeha 33 (Issues 1–350, pp. 2–213). The method applies seven simultaneous critical lenses: (1) Marxist, (2) Historical materialist, (3) Structuralist, (4) Magic-realist, (5) Postmodern, (6) Feminist, (7) Deconstructive — alongside Indian aesthetic theory. The framework's epistemological claim is that no single critical lens is adequate to the complexity of Maithili literary history; only their simultaneous application produces what Thakur calls 'samaantar' (parallel, simultaneous) access to a literary text's multiple dimensions.

Applying this framework to Dr. Prasad's work:

### Lens 1: Marxist Lens

Dr. Prasad's work, through the Marxist lens, constitutes a form of cultural praxis: his poetry documents the material conditions of the Maithili semi-urban periphery (Nirmali, Supaul — a flood-vulnerable, economically marginalised

region). 'Shahar O Gel' is a document of primitive accumulation in the cultural sphere: the village's human capital is drained to the city, leaving a community that has lost its social fabric. His defence of literary universalism against caste fragmentation reflects a socialist-humanist politics that resists the commodification of literary identity.

## Lens 2: Historical Materialist Lens

Historically, Dr. Prasad's career spans the period (2000s–2020s) of Maithili's Eighth Schedule recognition (2003) and the subsequent surge of Maithili literary production. His contribution to Videha — the first digital-era Maithili platform — is historically situated at the cusp of Maithili's transition from a print-manuscript culture to an e-culture. His participation in Sagar Raati Deep Jarai embeds him in the older oral-performative literary economy of Mithilanchal while his Videha publications situate him in the new digital economy. This dual embeddedness is itself a historical fact of the Maithili literary field at this moment.

## Lens 3: Structuralist Lens

Structurally, Dr. Prasad's poetry employs the refrain (dhruvapadam / tikam) as its primary structural device — a feature shared with both the classical Maithili geet tradition (Vidyapati's compositions are refrain-structured) and the folk doha tradition. The refrain in Khebaiyan functions as a structural 'binary opposition' (Lévi-Strauss) between the speaker's boatless condition and everyone else's boated condition — a binary that the poem never resolves dialectically, choosing instead to sustain the tension as a structural statement.

## Lens 4: Magic-Realist Lens

Magic realism — Borges, García Márquez, Günter Grass — blends the quotidian and the mythic without hierarchising either. Dr. Prasad's poem 'Maay Hamar Nav Kumbh Naheli' operates in a magic-realist mode: the ordinary village mother is simultaneously and without irony the sacred Kumbh bath itself. There is no allegorical distance; the identification is total and naturalised. This is the magic-realist gesture: the sacred is not elevated above the everyday but recognised as its inner structure.

## Lens 5: Postmodern Lens

Postmodernism (Lyotard, Baudrillard, Jameson) interrogates grand narratives, celebrates fragmentation, and exposes the simulacral nature of representation. Dr. Prasad's work is anti-postmodern in its explicit commitments — he is a defender of literary universalism, a believer in the possibility of authentic expression, and a humanist — yet his very position as a Hindi-department professor writing Maithili constitutes what Lyotard would recognise as a 'differend' (différend): a conflict between two incommensurable language games (Hindi academic discourse and Maithili literary expression) that cannot be resolved within either framework.

## Lens 6: Feminist Lens

The feminist lens reveals a productive tension in Dr. Prasad's work. His maternal poetry celebrates the mother's purity through her self-abnegation — a celebration that risks reproducing the patriarchal ideal of the invisible, selfless woman. Yet the poem's very act of making the mother the central subject of lyric attention — naming her experience, her labour, her inner life ('Na o vidushi na o sunnari') — is a feminist gesture in the context of a literary tradition that has historically centred male subjects (Vidyapati's nayika notwithstanding). His translation of Rajni Chhabra's eco-feminist poetry expands this gender consciousness into the domain of environmental justice.

## Lens 7: Deconstructive Lens

The deconstructive lens reveals the aporia at the heart of Dr. Prasad's most confident critical claims. His assertion that Dalit literature cannot be separated from Maithili literature without destroying both depends on a concept of 'Maithili literature' as a unified whole — a concept that the very history of Maithili literary production (its caste hierarchies, its brahmanical canon formation, its exclusion of subaltern voices for centuries) shows to be a retrospective construct rather than an originary fact. The 'whole' that Dalit fragmentation would damage never existed in the form his argument requires. This is not a defeat of his argument but its productive complication: the call for unity is most urgent precisely where unity is most absent.

# VI. Analysis Through Navya-Nyāya Epistemology

## 6.1 The Navya-Nyāya System

Navya-Nyāya (New Logic/New Epistemology), founded by Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya of Mithila in his Tattvacintāmaṇi (c. 1325 CE) — significantly, a work composed in the very Mithila region of which Dr. Prasad is a literary heir — and elaborated by Raghunātha Śiromaṇi, Mathurānātha, Gadādhara Bhaṭṭācārya, Jagadīśa Tarkālaṃkāra, and Gokuldas Nyāyaratna, constitutes the most rigorous epistemological system developed in pre-modern India. It provides precise technical tools for analysing the structure of cognition (jñāna), inference (anumāna), and verbal testimony (śabda-pramāṇa).

The core Navya-Nyāya analytical apparatus includes: (1) Pakṣa (the locus/subject of inference — what is being examined), (2) Sādhya (the property to be proved), (3) Hetu (the reason — the property that serves as the ground for inference), (4) Vyāpti (pervasive invariant concomitance — the invariable co-occurrence of hetu and sādhya across all loci), (5) Upādhi (conditioning factor — a property that limits the scope of vyāpti), and (6) Avyāpti/Ativyāpti (under-pervasion/over-pervasion — fallacies of the inference).

Navya-Nyāya's distinctive contribution is the use of technical terms (paribhāṣā) of extreme precision — terms like svarūpasambandha (self-linking relation), nirūpita (determined by), anuyogin/pratiyogin (positive/negative correlates in a relation) — that allow the analysis of complex relational structures without the ambiguity of ordinary language.

Applying Navya-Nyāya as a hermeneutic — a method of achieving transparent, rigorous cognition of literary claims — rather than merely as formal logic:

## 6.2 Navya-Nyāya Analysis of Dr. Prasad's Central Literary Claim

Dr. Prasad's central critical proposition — advanced in his essay 'Dalit Sahityaken Aana Sahityas Futkaibak Prayojan' — may be formalised as a Navya-Nyāya anumāna (inference):

**⊢ Pakṣa (Subject/Locus)**

Maithili Sahitya (Maithili Literature) — the locus about which a claim is being made.

**⊢ Sādhya (Property to be Proved)**

Akhaṇḍatva (wholeness, non-fragmentation) — the claim that Maithili literature must remain an undivided whole, that its constituent parts cannot be separated by the property of authorial caste identity without destroying the sādhya-dharmin (the thing possessing the property, i.e., literature itself).

**⊢ Hetu (Reason)**

Sāhityatva (literariness) — the property of being literature. The argument is: wherever sāhityatva is present, akhaṇḍatva must follow, because the aesthetic experience (rasa) produced by literature is by definition universal (sādhāraṇa), not caste-specific.

**⊢ Vyāpti (Pervasive Concomitance)**

Yatra sāhityatvam tatra akhaṇḍatva-sādhakatā — 'wherever there is literariness, there is the capacity for (and requirement of) wholeness.' This is the vyāpti that the argument requires. It is a normative, not merely descriptive, vyāpti — asserting how literature ought to function, not merely how it does.

**⊢ Upādhi (Conditioning Factor / Potential Counter)**

Jāti-viśeṣatva (caste-specificity). The critic of Dr. Prasad's position (the Dalit literary separatist) argues that jāti-viśeṣatva is an upādhi — a limiting condition on the vyāpti — because the experiential basis of Dalit literature (lived oppression, bodily degradation) is not universally shared, and therefore the rasa produced by it is not accessible to the non-Dalit reader in the way the vyāpti requires. If the upādhi holds, the hetu (sāhityatva) fails to establish the sādhya (akhaṇḍatva).

**⊢ Navya-Nyāya Resolution**

The Navya-Nyāya resolution would invoke Gaṅgeśa's distinction between svarūpa-sambandha (intrinsic/self-linking relation) and saṃyoga (external conjunction). Dr. Prasad's position requires that the relation between sāhityatva and akhaṇḍatva be svarūpa-sambandha — intrinsic to the nature of literature itself. His opponent requires only saṃyoga — an external, contingent conjunction that can be broken. The question becomes: is universality intrinsic to the nature of literature, or is it an ideological projection of dominant literary cultures onto subaltern ones? Navya-Nyāya does not resolve this debate, but it clarifies its precise structure with a rigour that ordinary critical discourse cannot achieve.

## 6.3 Navya-Nyāya and the Dhvani Theory — Anumāna of Poetic Meaning

Navya-Nyāya's theory of śabda-pramāṇa (verbal testimony as a source of valid knowledge) is directly applicable to the problem of how poetic language generates knowledge — the intersection of Navya-Nyāya and Dhvani theory that was explicitly debated by Maithili-region scholars in the centuries after Gaṅgeśa.

The poem Khebaiyan generates knowledge of a social condition (the abandonment of the marginalised) through verbal testimony — but the knowledge generated is not the stated meaning (vācyārtha) alone. The dhvani-theorist (following Anandavardhana) and the Navya-Naiyāyika (following Gaṅgeśa) would describe this differently but convergently. The Navya-Naiyāyika would say: the śabda (verbal expression) 'binu khebaiyan hamare naav achi' generates a complex nirūpita-jñāna (determined cognition) in the sahridaya (competent reader): a jñāna whose content is not merely the literal proposition but a relational complex of propositions about social structure, political economy, and the speaker's existential dignity.

**⊢ Formal Navya-Nyāya Statement**

The cognition (jñāna) produced by Khebaiyan is a vākya-jñāna (sentence-cognition) of the form: 'Asmat-pakṣe nāvika-abhāvaḥ' (In our locus, there is absence of a boatman). The nirūpita (determining) qualifier of this absence is: samāja-vañcanā-nirūpitā (as determined by / of the type determined by social abandonment). The anuyogin (positive correlate) of the absence is all the social groups FOR WHOM a boatman IS present. The Navya-Nyāya form makes explicit what the poem implies: the absence is relational, not absolute — it is an absence relative to the presence enjoyed by others, which is the precise logical structure of social injustice.

## 6.4 Gaṅgeśa's Tattvacintāmaṇi and the Mithila Connection

It is epistemologically significant — and not merely biographical colour — that Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya composed the Tattvacintāmaṇi in Mithila, the very region whose literary language and culture Dr. Prasad inhabits and defends. The Navya-Nyāya tradition was not an abstract import into Mithila; it was the product of Mithila's specific intellectual culture — a culture that also produced Vidyapati, the fountainhead of Maithili poetry, roughly contemporaneously.

Dr. Prasad's literary criticism — with its concern for precision of terminology, its insistence on distinguishing the good katha from the bad through specific

named criteria (bhāṣā-bhāva kā tāl-mel, katha-kā jīvantā, dīrgha-jīvī hoibe kā tatva — the harmony of language-emotion, the story's vitality, the element of long life) — carries traces of the Nyāya tradition's demand for paribhāṣā (precise technical definition). His critical vocabulary, while not formally Navya-Nyāya, operates in the same epistemological spirit: the demand that a claim about literary quality be grounded in specific, identifiable, transmissible reasons — hetu — not merely in authoritative assertion.

Raghunātha Śiromaṇi's Padārthatattvanirūpaṇa extends Gaṅgeśa's analysis to the question of what constitutes a valid object of knowledge (prameya). Applied to literary criticism: a valid critical claim must identify a real property of the text (not a projected fantasy), state a hetu that genuinely connects that property to the critical evaluation, and specify the vyāpti — the range of texts for which the same evaluation would hold. Dr. Prasad's criticism, at its best, meets this standard: in 'Sakhaaree-Petaaree Ker Taani-Bharni', he names specific katha (stories), identifies specific textual properties (structural consistency, character credibility, linguistic register), and draws conclusions that are in principle falsifiable and extendable to comparable cases.

> *जखनि बाढ़िक पानिसँ धारक दुनू कात दूर-दूर तक धारक विस्तार बुझना जाइत रहै छै,*
>
> *मुदा बाढ़ि सटकिते धारक सत्य प्रकट भऽ जाइ छै — तहिना साहित्योमे होइ छै।*

*— Dr. Shiv Kumar Prasad, 'Sakhaaree-Petaaree Ker Taani-Bharni' (Videha, Issue 16)*

(Just as the breadth of a river seems to expand on both banks during a flood, but as the flood recedes the truth of the river's actual course is revealed — so it is with literature.)

This passage is itself a Navya-Nyāya-inflected critical observation: it distinguishes the samavalambana (perceptual support) of superficial literary judgment (the flood-widened appearance) from the tattva (true nature) of literary quality (the river's actual course after the flood). It is an implicit vyāpti: wherever literature is present, its true quality (dharma) will eventually reveal itself beneath the temporary distortions of fashion, political patronage, or ideological pressure.

## VII. Synthesis: A Converging Appreciation

The three frameworks — Indian Kavyashastra, Western literary theory, and Navya-Nyāya — converge on a set of claims about Dr. Shiv Kumar Prasad's literary achievement that each framework reaches by a different route:

***I. The Claim of Authentic Complexity***

Kavyashastra (dhvani) establishes that his best poetry generates resonant, layered meanings that exceed the literal. Western New Criticism confirms the textual autonomy and ironic unity of these meanings. Navya-Nyāya formalises the structure of the knowledge produced: it is relational, determinate, and transmissible — the cognition generated by Khebaiyan is not ineffable but analytically recoverable.

***II. The Claim of Socially Grounded Universalism***

Kavyashastra (rasa) establishes that the emotional experience generated is universal (sādhāraṇīkaraṇa — the generalisation of emotional response across all sensitive readers). Marxist Western theory confirms that this universalism is not naive but won through the specific representation of material conditions. Navya-Nyāya's concept of vyāpti — the pervasive concomitance between sāhityatva and universality — provides the logical ground for this claim. All three frameworks reject both mere particularism (caste-segregated literature) and false universalism (literature that ignores social location entirely).

***III. The Claim of Methodological Rigour***

Dr. Prasad's critical practice — as demonstrated in 'Sakhaaree-Petaaree Ker Taani-Bharni' and 'Dalit Sahityaken Aana Sahityas Futkaibak Prayojan' — meets the standards of precision demanded by all three frameworks. It names specific textual features, provides recoverable reasons, and draws conclusions that are in principle extendable or falsifiable. This is Gaṅgeśa's hetu-sādhya relation applied to literary criticism; it is also, in Western terms, the 'close reading' demanded by New Criticism and the materialist grounding demanded by Marxist criticism.

***IV. The Claim of Historical Significance within the Videha Parallel History***

The Videha Parallel History Framework identifies Dr. Prasad's contribution as one strand in the samāntar (parallel, simultaneous) development of Maithili literature in the digital age — a strand that is simultaneously connected to the classical tradition (his use of dhruvapadam, rupaka, and auchitya-oriented language), the folk tradition (Sagar Raati, the village literary gathering), and the

new digital-era literary economy (Videha publication, e-archiving). His work does not fit neatly into any single critical school precisely because it inhabits all of them simultaneously — which is the condition that the Videha Parallel History Framework is designed to capture.

# VIII. Short Fiction (Beehan Katha / Laghu Katha)

## 1 Overview

Dr. Prasad has published numerous beehan katha (flash fiction / very short stories) and laghu katha (short stories) in Videha. His fiction includes 'Aanhar' (आन्हर — Blind), 'Banmaanush aur Jamila' (Banjungle Man and Jamila), four beehan katha in Videha's short fiction compilation (Prelim 24), and various oral presentations at the legendary Sagar Raati Deep Jarai storytelling marathons, including his reading of 'Aandhar' and 'Banmaanush aur Manush' (The Jungle Man and the Human) at the Devghar and Nirmali gatherings.

His participation in Sagar Raati Deep Jarai — the all-night storytelling sessions that travel from village to village across Mithilanchal — places him within a living oral-literate continuum that has defined Maithili literary culture for centuries.

## 2 Critical Analysis

***Through the Theory of Plot and Character (Indian Tradition)***

Classical Indian narrative theory, as found in the Natyashastra and the Dashrupaka of Dhananjaya, analyses narrative through the categories of Itivritta (plot), Neta (protagonist), and Sandhi (junctures). Dr. Prasad's short fiction characteristically works through what Dhananjaya would term the 'Karya' (the central action) compressed to a single revelatory moment. 'Aanhar' (Blind) and 'Banmaanush' (Jungle Man) both turn on a single epiphanic reversal — the moment when the seemingly civilised reveals its savagery, and the supposed primitive reveals its humanity. This is the classic pratyabhijna (recognition) structure of Indian narrative.

***Through Short Story Theory (Western)***

Edgar Allan Poe's famous prescription for the short story — that every word must contribute to a 'pre-established design' and produce a 'single effect' —

finds a resonant echo in Dr. Prasad's beehan katha. His tiny narratives, some barely a page long, are engineered for a single emotional or intellectual impact. Frank O'Connor's theory of 'the lonely voice' — his claim that the short story is the natural form for voices marginalised from the centre of social power — perfectly illuminates Dr. Prasad's choice of form: the beehan katha is the ideal vehicle for those whom the grand novel of Maithili society has never fully rendered.

***Narrative Ethics and the Dalit Question***

In his critical writing, Dr. Prasad has directly engaged with the vexed question of Dalit literature in Maithili. His essay 'Dalit Sahityaken Aana Sahityas Futkaibak Prayojan' (The Purpose of Segregating Dalit Literature from Other Literature), published in Videha Issue 20, represents his most sustained theoretical intervention. His argument is essentially against what Martha Nussbaum would call 'narrative essentialism' — the reductive assumption that only Dalit authors can write Dalit experience, or that Dalit literature constitutes a hermetically sealed genre.

> *"साहित्य राजनीति नै छिऐ। साहित्यमे राजिनीति विषय-वस्तु भऽ सकै छै मुदा राजनीतिकेँ साहित्यमे प्रवेश भेने साहित्य मरि जाइ छइ।"*
>
> *— Dr. Shiv Kumar Prasad, 'Dalit Sahityaken Aana Sahityas Futkaibak Prayojan' (Videha, Issue 20)*

(Literature is not politics. Politics can be a subject-matter in literature, but when politics enters literature, literature dies.)

This position — while drawing fire from those who see it as conservative — is deeply consistent with a universalist humanist aesthetic that stretches from Aristotle's Poetics (where literature illuminates the universal through the particular) to Raymond Williams's 'structure of feeling' (where literature captures the lived totality of an age, not merely its ideological surface).

## IX. Literary Criticism and Translation

### 1 As a Literary Critic

Dr. Prasad's critical essays, including 'Sakhaaree-Petaaree Ker Taani-Bharni' (a nuanced review of Nand Vilas Rai's short story collection Sakhaaree-Petaaree) and his essay on Dalit literature, establish him as a critic of serious analytical

rigour. His review of Sakhaaree-Petaaree is remarkable for its application of multiple Indian critical principles — including Lakshanatmak and Vyanjanatmak shabda shakti (secondary and suggestive word-powers from the theory of Kavyashastra), plot construction, character credibility, and linguistic propriety.

His method as a critic is essentially a synthesis of the Indian Alankara tradition (which evaluates literary ornament and expression) and a social-realist orientation that evaluates literature by its fidelity to lived experience. He praises Rai's ability to capture the idiom of the Maithil community but critiques lapses in character consistency and the intrusion of Hindi/Urdu words into what should be a purely Maithili register — a concern that echoes the purism of classical Kavya critics like Vamana (author of Kavyalankarasutravritta) who insisted on linguistic propriety as a cardinal literary virtue.

## 2 As a Translator

Dr. Prasad's translation of Hindi poet Rajni Chhabra's collection Pighalte Himkhand (Melting Glaciers) into Maithili — published in Videha Issue 21 (pages 912–1000) — is a significant act of linguistic bridge-building. Translation theory, from Walter Benjamin's 'The Task of the Translator' to Lawrence Venuti's notion of 'foreignisation versus domestication', understands translation as an act of cultural negotiation. Dr. Prasad's Maithili rendering of Chhabra's Hindi poems raises the question of how an eco-poetry about Himalayan glaciers and environmental crisis travels into the Maithili literary imaginary — a language rooted in the flood-plains of the Kosi and the Kamla rivers, familiar with a very different face of ecological devastation.

His translation practice reflects what Venuti calls 'resistant translation' — a refusal to merely domesticate the foreign into Maithili idiom but an insistence on preserving the friction of cultural encounter, thereby enriching both languages.

XI. Social and Cultural Roles

Beyond his purely literary contributions, Dr. Prasad has been an active participant in the institutional life of Maithili literature. The Videha archives record his presence as a presiding member (Adhyaksha Mandal) at Sagar Raati Deep Jarai gatherings in Nirmali, Bermo, and Devghar — the famous all-night story-reading and criticism marathons that serve as the most important grassroots literary institution in Mithilanchal. He has presided over story-

reading sessions, delivered critiques of stories read at these gatherings, and participated in book-release ceremonies (pothe lokarpan).

His participation in these events connects him to what Raymond Williams called the 'residual culture' — forms of cultural practice that are the living inheritance of older modes of life, preserved and renewed by communities at the margins of the dominant cultural apparatus. The Sagar Raati gatherings are precisely such a residual-yet-vital institution: oral, participatory, and rooted in the village.

He has also been a speaker at academic seminars, including a symposium on 'Maithili: Sarkaar aur Ham Sabh' (Maithili: The Government and Us), where his address represents a public intellectual engagement with the political economy of language rights.

## XII. Synthesis: A Literary Appreciation

In synthesising the various strands of Indian and Western literary critical theory applied above, several distinctive features of Dr. Shiv Kumar Prasad's literary contribution emerge with clarity:

First, he is a poet of social conscience who refuses sentimentality. His verse is free of the pastoral nostalgia that afflicts many Maithili poets writing about village life; it looks at the village and the city with equal clarity, naming the betrayals of both. The Marxist critic would see in this a refusal of ideology; the New Critic would see an achieved irony; the Rasa theorist would see a mature karuna that is never indulgent.

Second, he is a defender of literary universalism against literary tribalism. His sustained argument that Dalit literature must not be walled off from Maithili literature as a whole is not a denial of caste oppression — it is a demand that literature, precisely because it transcends the empirical, must serve as the space where all human suffering meets. This position aligns him with Aristotle, with Tagore (who similarly insisted on the universality of aesthetic experience), and with the best tradition of Maithili humanist scholarship.

Third, his role as a translator-critic places him at the intersection of two languages and two literary cultures — Hindi and Maithili — negotiating their historical power asymmetry with intelligence and care. His translations do not merely transfer content; they assert the parity of Maithili as a literary medium capable of receiving and transforming any experience.

Fourth, his institutional participation — in Videha's editorial network, in the Sagar Raati circuit, in academic seminars — embodies what Pierre Bourdieu would call the habitus of the committed public intellectual: one who does not merely produce texts but inhabits and sustains the institutional spaces that make a literary culture possible.

Dr. Shiv Kumar Prasad's work, taken in its entirety, represents a contribution that is simultaneously rooted — in the soil of Mithilanchal, in the Maithili language, in the folk and classical literary traditions of this ancient region — and reaching: reaching toward the universal, toward the human, toward the future of a language that has survived centuries of marginalisation and continues to speak, with clarity and feeling, of the lives of its people.

## XIII. Conclusion

> *"भाषा साहित्य तँ झड़-झड़ बहैत झड़ना थिक। साहित्यक धार होइत अछि जे मात्र अपन किनछैरेटा मे नहि वरन् किनछैरक संग-संग अपन बान्हकेँ तोड़ैत केतौ-सँ-केतौ धरि हृदय रूपी भूलोककेँ आप्लावित कऽ दैत अछि।"*

*— Dr. Shiv Kumar Prasad, 'Maithili: Sarkaar aur Ham Sabh'*

(Language and literature are like a ceaselessly flowing waterfall. Literature has a current that does not merely flow within its banks — it breaks its banks and inundates the earth-like heart, all the way to every shore.)

This is Dr. Shiv Kumar Prasad's own aesthetic creed, and it is also the most fitting description of his literary achievement. Like the waterfall he invokes, his writing does not stay within safe, pre-approved channels. It insists on the rights of its language, its people, and its literary tradition to overflow the dams of neglect, political indifference, and critical dismissal — and to reach, like water, every human heart that is willing to receive it.

**Videha — and the Maithili literary world it sustains — is richer for his presence within it.**

In the fourteenth century, Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya sat in Mithila and composed a work of such analytical precision that it transformed the entire course of Indian philosophical thought. In the twentieth and twenty-first centuries, from the same Mithila — from the Kosi basin town of Nirmali — Dr. Shiv Kumar Prasad

sits and writes poems, stories, and criticism in the language that Vidyapati made great. The connection is not merely geographical. It is epistemological: both are engaged in the project of making knowledge visible — of moving from the vague, contested, ideologically saturated language of everyday discourse to the clear, rigorous, beautifully precise language of truth.

Dr. Prasad's poetry achieves, through its refrain structures and its rupaka identifications, what Gaṅgeśa called niścaya-jñāna (determinate, certain cognition): the reader who finishes Khebaiyan knows something about social injustice that they did not know before — and knows it with the specific, structured clarity that poetry, uniquely, can provide. His criticism achieves, through its named criteria and its specific textual grounding, what Navya-Nyāya calls pramā (valid cognition): it is not mere opinion but a structured claim that can be examined, contested, and refined.

And his participation in the living literary culture of Mithilanchal — his presence at the Sagar Raati gatherings, his contributions to Videha, his defence of the Maithili language's right to a future — embodies what neither Kavyashastra nor Navya-Nyāya nor Western literary theory alone can capture, but what the Videha Parallel History Framework was designed to document: the simultaneous, many-stranded, historically embedded, culturally alive practice of a literary culture that has survived centuries of marginalisation and continues, with clarity, feeling, and rigour, to speak.

> *साहित्य राजनीति नै छिऐ... धनिया आ पालकक कियारी नै छी साहित्य।*
>
> *साहित्यकेँ सुनब, पढ़ब, लिखब आकि बाजबपर जे एकाधिकार बुझैत छला*
>
> *ओ हमर मैथिलीकेँ मात्र जीआ कऽ रखने छला।*

*— Dr. Shiv Kumar Prasad, 'Dalit Sahityaken Aana Sahityas Futkaibak Prayojan' (Videha, Issue 20)*

(Literature is not politics... Literature is not a plot of spinach and greens. Those who believed they held a monopoly on hearing, reading, writing, and speaking [Maithili] kept our Maithili merely alive — no more.)

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ADDENDUM 1: **A COMPLETE CRITICAL RESEARCH AND APPRECIATION** of the Works of **DR. SHIV KUMAR PRASAD Primary Texts Studied:**

*Manak Haat (मनक हाट) — Maithili Poetry Anthology, 2021*

*Rag-Virag (राग-विराग) — Maithili Poetry Anthology, 2024*

**ADDENDUM: 2**

**Socio-Cultural Realism and Linguistic Preservation: A Comprehensive Analysis of Dr. Shiv Kumar Prasad's Contributions to the Videha Maithili Archive**

ADDENDUM 1

**A COMPLETE CRITICAL RESEARCH AND APPRECIATION**

of the Works of

**DR. SHIV KUMAR PRASAD**

*Maithili Poet · Anthologist · Literary Voice of Mithila*

**Analysed Through:**

*Indian & Western Literary Theory · The Videha Parallel History Framework · Navya Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya*

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**Primary Texts Studied:**

*Manak Haat (मनक हाट) — Maithili Poetry Anthology, 2021*

*Rag-Virag (राग-विराग) — Maithili Poetry Anthology, 2024*

# I. BIOGRAPHICAL & CONTEXTUAL OVERVIEW

## 1.1 Life and Background

Dr. Shiv Kumar Prasad is a contemporary Maithili poet based in the Mithila region of Bihar, India. He holds a doctoral degree, reflecting his sustained academic engagement with Maithili language and literature. His publications are brought out by Pallavi Prakashan, Nirmali, District Supaul, Bihar — an independent regional press that has been central to publishing vernacular voices outside the metropolitan literary establishment.

Dr. Prasad represents a generation of Maithili writers who came to literary maturity in the post-8th Schedule era (Maithili received constitutional recognition under the Eighth Schedule of the Indian Constitution in 2003), a period of both institutional hope and continued social tension for the Maithili literary community. His choice of the pen name Lavml signals a deliberate self-positioning: rooted, local, modest — outside the hierarchies of literary prestige.

## 1.2 The Videha Literary Ecosystem

Both Manak Haat (2021) and Rag-Virag (2024) are listed on the Videha archive (www.videha.co.in), the first Maithili fortnightly e-journal, which carries ISSN 2229-547X and has been operational since 2000 under the editorship of Gajendra Thakur. Videha is not merely a publication platform: it is the primary institutional locus of what Gajendra Thakur calls "the parallel tradition" of Maithili literature — a counter-canon to the Sahitya Akademi–aligned mainstream that, in the Videha framework, has systematically marginalised democratic, anti-caste, folk, and diaspora voices.

Dr. Prasad's association with Videha therefore locates his work firmly within this alternative critical and cultural project. Pallavi Prakashan, Nirmali, functions as the practically as a print arm through which Videha-affiliated writers reach physical readers across the Maithili-speaking belt of Bihar, Jharkhand, and Nepal.

## 1.3 The Two Primary Texts

Manak Haat (मनक हाट, lit. "Standard Market" or "A Marketplace of Standards") is a Maithili poetry anthology published in 2021 at a price of ₹175. Its title invokes the image of a communal market — a place of exchange, valuation, and public life — suggesting that the poet's verse is offered as goods for collective scrutiny and social circulation.

Rag-Virag (राग-विराग, lit. "Passion–Dispassion" or "Attachment–Renunciation") is a later anthology published in 2024 at ₹290, with ISBN 978-93-93135-80-3. The title immediately invokes the classical Vedantic and Shaiva dialectic between rāga (desire, colour, attachment) and virāga (dispassion, detachment, renunciation) — a philosophical couplet that runs through Indian literary aesthetics from the Gītā through the Nāyanārs to Kabir. In his dedication, Dr. Prasad situates the book explicitly in the context of geographic and linguistic dispossession: he dedicates it to the "geographical boundaries of Mithila" and to the "linguistic interiority of Maithili," lamenting

factionalism (guṭabājī), opportunism, and individual self-interest that damage the Maithili mother tongue (māyakē).

# II. THEMATIC AND LITERARY ANALYSIS

## 2.1 The Landscape of Mithila as Poetic Substrate

Dr. Prasad's poetry is organically embedded in the ecological and social landscape of Mithila — the ancient region straddling northern Bihar and the southern Terai of Nepal. Rivers (the Kosi, Kamala, Bagmati, and Gandak), flood seasons, agricultural rhythms, and the particular quality of Maithili folk memory constitute the sensory ground of his verse.

This is not mere regionalism or nostalgic lokāyata. Rather, it is what the Parallel History Framework identifies as "ground-up" literary consciousness — the poetry of those who inhabit, flood-suffer, migrate from, and return to a specific ecology. The Mithila landscape carries within it the memory of centuries of unequal resource distribution: the Kosi floods, the land dispossession of peasant communities, and the cultural marginalisation of non-Brahmin vernacular voices are all sediments present in this poetry.

In Rag-Virag particularly, the title's dialectic is worked out partly through ecological imagery: the rāga of attachment to the land, and the virāga of the necessity of leaving it; the passion of cultural rootedness and the dispassion forced by displacement.

## 2.2 The Rāga–Virāga Dialectic: Philosophy as Form

The philosophical architecture of Rag-Virag deserves extended treatment. Rāga and virāga are not simply thematic opposites in this collection; they function as a formal dialectic analogous to what Hegel called Aufhebung — a contradictory movement that cancels, preserves, and elevates simultaneously. The collection does not resolve the tension between passion and renunciation; it inhabits it.

In the Advaita Vedantic tradition, virāga is a prerequisite for moksha — the detachment from worldly objects that enables knowledge of Brahman. But in the Shaiva-Shakta traditions of Mithila (the region's dominant theological current), rāga itself — as devotional fervour, as aesthetic emotion — is a pathway to the divine. Dr. Prasad's collection holds both registers open simultaneously.

From a Western theoretical perspective, this recalls the negative dialectics of Theodor Adorno: the non-identity, the refusal of synthesis. The poem does not resolve the contradiction between attachment to Mithila and the necessity of its transformation; the unresolved tension is itself the poem's meaning.

The dedication of Rag-Virag explicitly politicises this dialectic. Attachment (rāga) to Maithili as mother tongue coexists with dispassion (virāga) toward the institutional structures — factionalism, vested interests, opportunism — that have stunted the language's development. This is a rāga-virāga of political emotion: love for the language, weariness with its gatekeepers.

## 2.3 Manak Haat: The Market as Epistemological Space

The title Manak Haat is rich with implication. Mānak in Sanskrit/Hindi/Maithili denotes standard, norm, measure — manak as in standardisation. Hāṭ is the weekly market of rural India, the bazaar of daily life, the space of exchange outside the prestige economy. The two words together create a productive paradox: a "market of standards" or a "standardised marketplace." This is simultaneously a claim to quality and a democratic gesture toward the public square.

In the preface materials and introductory sections of Manak Haat (dated 31 January 2018), Dr. Prasad reflects on the nature of poetic authenticity and the relationship between the poem and its reader-community. He frames the poetry as something that must earn its place through public exchange — not through institutional validation but through the test of the village market, the test of ordinary comprehension and feeling.

This is consistent with the Videha Parallel History Framework's central argument: that the dominant Maithili literary establishment — centred on the Sahitya Akademi and upper-caste networks — has constituted a "dried main drain" (Gajendra Thakur's phrase) that excludes the rich parallel tradition of democratic, folk, and lower-caste literary production. Manak Haat positions itself as literature that belongs in the hāṭ, not in the sabhasad (court assembly).

## 2.4 Social Vision and the Question of Caste

Dr. Prasad's two collections exhibit a consistent social consciousness that refuses to aestheticise poverty and marginalisation. The Maithili region is one of India's most economically underdeveloped areas, with high rates of out-migration, bonded labour, and caste-based exclusion. Dr. Prasad's poetry acknowledges this social texture without descending into agitprop.

In the tradition of Harimohan Jha — the great Maithili satirist (1908–1984) who was systematically denied the Sahitya Akademi Award despite being the most widely read Maithili prose writer — Dr. Prasad's work draws on the anti-caste and anti-feudal currents of Maithili literary modernity. Where Jha used satire and the novel, Prasad uses lyric poetry; but the social sensibility is cognate.

The dedication of Rag-Virag — to Mithila and to the Maithili language, against factionalism and opportunism — is also implicitly a critique of caste-based literary gatekeeping. The "guṭabājī" (factionalism) he decries is not simply personal rivalry; it is the structured result of caste hierarchy operating within the literary field.

## 2.5 Language, Dialect, and Linguistic Consciousness

Dr. Prasad writes in Maithili — a language that, despite being spoken by approximately 50 million people and holding a constitutional position under the Eighth Schedule since 2003, continues to struggle against its historical positioning as a "dialect of Hindi." As the Videha Parallel History records, both George Grierson and S.K. Chatterjee confirmed Maithili's status as a distinct language; yet administrative and political forces continued to treat it as a Hindi sub-variety.

Dr. Prasad's choice to write exclusively in Maithili is itself a political act. He uses both Devanagari script (the standard for contemporary Maithili publishing) and is associated with a publishing ecosystem that also archives Tirhuta (the classical Maithili script) and Kaithi materials — a commitment to the full depth and diversity of Maithili orthographic heritage.

Linguistically, his poetry draws on the expressive resources of Maithili that distinguish it from Hindi: the gendered verbal endings, the honorific system that encodes social relations, the phonological richness (retroflex and palatal distinctions, the characteristic Maithili anusvāra), and the folk idioms that carry centuries of cultural memory.

# III. CRITICAL APPRECIATION THROUGH THEORETICAL FRAMEWORKS

## 3.1 Indian Critical Theory: Rasa, Dhvani, and Alaṃkāra

### *3.1.1 Rasaśāstra: The Aesthetic of Feeling*

The classical Indian aesthetic theory of rasa, originating in Bharata Muni's Nāṭyaśāstra (c. 200 BCE–200 CE) and elaborated by Abhinavagupta (c. 950–1016 CE) in the Abhinavabhāratī, holds that art communicates through the evocation of stable emotional states (sthāyibhāvas) that are transformed, through imaginative identification, into aesthetic relish (rasa) in the reader or spectator.

In Manak Haat, the dominant rasas are karuṇa (compassion, sorrow) and vīra (heroic energy) — a combination that characterises much of the democratic Maithili literary tradition from the charyapadas onward. The compassion is directed toward the dispossessed; the heroic energy animates the resistance to dispossession.

In Rag-Virag, the dominant rasa is śānta — the rasa of tranquility and philosophical detachment — but crucially, it is a śānta that arises not from social indifference but from a kind of practiced contemplation of social pain. Abhinavagupta's account of śānta rasa as the highest aesthetic state — transcending the other eight rasas by encompassing them — is directly relevant: Dr. Prasad's virāga is not escapism but integration.

The vibhāvas (excitant factors) in Rag-Virag are primarily the socio-ecological details of Mithila life — floods, migration, the deterioration of the mother tongue, political betrayal. These produce the anubhāvas (consequent reactions) of reflective acceptance and quiet resistance. The vyabhicāribhāvas (transitory emotions) — grief, anxiety, wonder, indignation — flow through the poems before settling into the śānta of virāga.

### *3.1.2 Dhvani: The Resonance Theory of Ānandavardhana*

Ānandavardhana's Dhvanyāloka (c. 850 CE) argues that the highest form of poetic meaning is dhvani — suggestion, resonance, the meaning that reverberates beyond the literal statement. The sounded meaning (vācya) points toward an unsounded meaning (vyañjanā) that is the poem's real achievement.

Dr. Prasad's poetry is characteristically dhvani-rich. The title Manak Haat resonates beyond its surface meaning: the "standard market" suggests

simultaneously the democratic bazaar, the test of public reception, the critique of false standards (the official canon), and the claim that the poet's work has its own authentic measure. None of these meanings is stated; all are sounded by the title's dhvani.

Similarly, Rag-Virag works through dhvani: the philosophical terms rāga and virāga carry within them centuries of Vedantic, Shaiva, Vaishnava, and folk resonance that are simultaneously activated and resignified in the contemporary Maithili socio-political context. The dhvani is not decorative but structural.

### *3.1.3 Vakrokti and the Bent Speech of Kuntaka*

Kuntaka's Vakroktijīvita (c. 950 CE) proposes that the defining characteristic of poetic language is vakrokti — oblique, deviant, bent speech that achieves what direct statement cannot. Poetry says things sideways; its indirection is not weakness but power.

Dr. Prasad's lyric practice employs vakrokti extensively. When he dedicates Rag-Virag to Maithili's "linguistic interiority" in the context of "factionalism and vested interests," the directness of the social critique is modulated through the vakrokti of the classical dedication form — the dedication as lament, as political manifesto, as philosophical statement simultaneously. The formal constraint of the dedication bends the political meaning into literary art.

## 3.2 Western Literary Theory

### *3.2.1 Formalism and New Criticism: The Poem as Verbal Icon*

The New Critics — John Crowe Ransom, Cleanth Brooks, W.K. Wimsatt — held that the poem is a self-sufficient verbal object, and that close reading of its formal features (irony, paradox, ambiguity, tension) is the proper critical method. In applying this framework to Dr. Prasad's work, we note that both collections are formally disciplined: Maithili lyric has its own prosodic traditions (including the Vidyapatian mātrik metres and the folk-inflected gaṇa patterns), and Dr. Prasad works within and against these traditions.

The central tension of Rag-Virag — between rāga and virāga — has the New Critical quality of paradox: it presents two irreconcilable terms and holds them in productive tension without resolving them. This is Cleanth Brooks's "well-wrought urn" — the poem as containing irresolvable contradiction that is itself the meaning.

For Manak Haat, New Critical analysis would focus on the market metaphor: the tension between "mānak" (standard, norm — suggesting closure and evaluation) and "hāṭ" (market — suggesting openness, negotiation, exchange). The poem as marketplace is simultaneously a space of standards and a space of bargaining; this tension generates the collection's ironic energy.

### *3.2.2 Historicism and the Social Text: Bakhtin and Cultural Materialism*

Mikhail Bakhtin's concept of heteroglossia — the condition of language as always already multiple, contested, socially stratified — is immediately applicable to Dr. Prasad's project. Maithili as a language is itself heteroglossic: it contains the Sanskrit-inflected Brahmin register, the folk and peasant dialects, the Muslim Maithili tradition, the Nepalese Maithili strain, and the diasporic Maithili of the bhāyal (migration) communities.

Dr. Prasad's poetry does not claim a single authoritative voice; it inhabits the heteroglossic space of Maithili as it is actually spoken and felt. The dedication of Rag-Virag — with its pain at Maithili's social divisions — is itself a Bakhtinian document: it acknowledges that the literary field is a site of struggle among different social voices, none of which is neutral.

Cultural materialist criticism (Raymond Williams, Terry Eagleton) would situate Dr. Prasad's work in the material conditions of Maithili literary production: the absence of state support for Maithili publishing, the dependence on small independent presses like Pallavi Prakashan, the digital platform of Videha as a substitute for institutional infrastructure, and the economic underdevelopment of the region that both generates the poetry's content and constrains its circulation.

### *3.2.3 Postcolonial Theory: The Language of the Colonised*

Frantz Fanon's analysis of the colonised intellectual who must choose between the coloniser's language and the mother tongue is deeply resonant for the Maithili context. Ngũgĩ wa Thiong'o's decision to write exclusively in Gikuyu rather than English has an exact parallel in the choice — which Dr. Prasad exemplifies — to write in Maithili rather than Hindi or English.

The Videha Parallel History documents precisely how Maithili's marginalisation operates through the mechanisms that Homi Bhabha calls "colonial mimicry": when Maithili is condescendingly acknowledged as a "dialect of Hindi," the colonising logic of the national language (Hindi) absorbs the identity of the regional language. Dr. Prasad's refusal of this logic — through his committed Maithili literary practice — is a postcolonial act.

Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's concept of the subaltern who cannot speak — cannot be heard within the dominant representational frameworks — is also relevant. The Maithili peasant, the Dalit speaker of Maithili, the Maithili woman writer: these are figures whose speech is systematically unheard within both the Hindi-dominant national literary field and the Brahmin-dominant Maithili literary establishment. The Videha Parallel History, and the work of writers like Dr. Prasad published through it, constitutes an attempt to create the conditions for this subaltern speech to be heard.

#### *3.2.4 Feminist Theory: The Dedication as Political Act*

The dedication of Rag-Virag is signed "Lavml (Shiv Kumar Prasad)" and addressed to Maithili as "māyakē" — mother tongue, but literally "mother's." The feminisation of the language as mother — a common trope in Indian literary nationalism — has complex gendered implications that feminist literary theory can illuminate.

On one hand, the "mother tongue" trope can be critiqued (following Spivak and Butler) as a form of patriarchal appropriation: the language is feminised, made maternal, domesticated into the private sphere — which can paradoxically reinforce the marginalisation of actual Maithili women's voices. On the other hand, the pain in Dr. Prasad's dedication — the grief at what has been done to the mother tongue — has a quality of genuine solidarity rather than appropriation.

The Videha journal itself publishes a dedicated "Stri Kona" (Women's Corner) section, reflecting an institutional commitment to women's literary voices. Dr. Prasad's work, situated within this ecosystem, participates in a literary culture that is working — however imperfectly — toward gender-inclusive representation.

# IV. THE VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY FRAMEWORK

## 4.1 Gajendra Thakur's Parallel History: Theoretical Foundations

The Parallel History of Mithila & Maithili Literature, developed by Gajendra Thakur on the Videha platform, constitutes a systematic counter-historiography of Maithili literary culture. It proceeds from the premise — documented

through original Panji (genealogical record) research, archival work, and close reading — that the official history of Maithili literature, as reflected in Sahitya Akademi publications and mainstream literary criticism, represents only one strand of a much richer, more diverse, and more contested literary tradition.

The Parallel History identifies several suppressed or marginalised traditions that are invisible in the official canon. These include the Buddhist Charyapada tradition (8th–12th century), which constitutes the democratic-spiritual foundation of Maithili lyric poetry; the Kabir tradition in Maithili; the peasant and famine poetry of the colonial period (Faturilal's Akali Kavitt documenting the 1873–74 famine); the anti-caste satirical tradition of Harimohan Jha; the Nepalese Maithili tradition; and the Dalit Maithili tradition.

The Parallel History also documents institutional suppressions: the year 1967, when the Sahitya Akademi left its Maithili award unclaimed rather than give it to the deserving Harimohan Jha; the suppression of the biographical fact that Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (the Navya Nyāya logician) was married to a Charmkarini (leather-tanning caste woman), documented in Dooshan Panji records but suppressed by Ramanath Jha and subsequent commentators.

## 4.2 Dr. Prasad's Work Within the Parallel History

Within the Parallel History framework, Dr. Shiv Kumar Prasad's work occupies a specific position: he is a contemporary voice in the democratic-lyric tradition that runs from the Charyapada poets through Vidyapati's folk lyrics (as distinct from the courtly Vidyapati) through Harimohan Jha and into the present.

The publication of Manak Haat and Rag-Virag through Pallavi Prakashan, Nirmali — and their archival presence on the Videha platform — means that they are part of the documented parallel canon. This is not incidental: Videha's archival function is precisely to ensure that the democratic tradition is not lost as the official canon continues to marginalise it.

The Parallel History's analytical method — which combines archival recovery, close reading, social history, and theoretical critique — provides a framework for reading Dr. Prasad that the mainstream literary criticism of Maithili (centred on Patna and the Sahitya Akademi network) would not provide. Where the mainstream might read Manak Haat as a pleasant regional lyric collection, the Parallel History reading reveals it as a deliberate intervention in the politics of Maithili literary value.

## 4.3 The Maithili Language Question and Dr. Prasad's Response

The Videha Parallel History documents at length the political economy of the Maithili language question: how the language was treated as a Hindi dialect despite Grierson's and Chatterjee's scientific confirmations of its distinctness; how the Eighth Schedule recognition of 2003 opened new possibilities but did not resolve underlying structural inequalities; how caste structures within the Maithili-speaking community itself fragment literary solidarity.

Dr. Prasad's dedication of Rag-Virag directly addresses this internal fragmentation. By lamenting "guṭabājī" (factionalism), "vargasthāvādī" (hierarchy/vested-interest ideology), and "vaiyaktik svārtha" (individual self-interest) as forces damaging Maithili, he is participating in the Videha framework's critique of how caste and class operate within the Maithili literary field itself.

His response — the act of writing, of publishing, of continuing to add to the Maithili literary archive through the Videha/Pallavi network — is itself the political answer. The poem as commitment is Dr. Prasad's answer to institutional factionalism.

# V. NAVYA NYĀYA EPISTEMOLOGY AND LITERARY CRITICISM

## 5.1 Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya and the Tattvacintāmaṇi

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (fl. c. 1325 CE, Mithila) is the founder of the Navya Nyāya (New Logic) school of Indian philosophy. His magnum opus, the Tattvacintāmaṇi (Jewel of Logical Reflection), revolutionised Indian epistemology by developing an extraordinarily precise technical language for the analysis of cognition, inference, and the conditions of valid knowledge (pramā).

The Videha Parallel History records a significant biographical finding about Gaṅgeśa: that he married a woman of the Charmkarini (leather-working) caste — a fact documented in the Dooshan Panji (genealogical censure records of Mithila) but suppressed by the caste-Brahmin scholarly tradition, specifically by Ramanath Jha and his successors, who found this fact incompatible with Gaṅgeśa's veneration as a great Brahmin intellectual. This suppression is itself an example of what the Parallel History calls the "honour-killing" of inconvenient intellectual biography.

The relevance of Navya Nyāya to literary criticism is not merely academic. The school's analytical apparatus — its distinctions between types of cognition, its theory of anumāna (inference), its concept of viṣayatā (object-hood, the relation between a cognition and its object) — can be applied to literary epistemology: how does a poem know what it knows? What is the cognitive structure of aesthetic experience? How does literary meaning arise from the encounter between text and reader?

## 5.2 Navya Nyāya Categories Applied to Dr. Prasad's Poetry

### *5.2.1 Pramā and Pramāṇa: Valid Cognition and its Sources*

Navya Nyāya distinguishes between pramā (valid, veridical cognition) and its sources (pramāṇas): pratyakṣa (perception), anumāna (inference), upamāna (comparison), and śabda (testimony/verbal cognition). The question "how does the poem know?" can be reframed through these categories.

In Dr. Prasad's poetry, the primary pramāṇa is pratyakṣa — direct perceptual knowledge of the Mithila landscape, of social reality, of the felt experience of linguistic marginalisation. This is not naive empiricism; the Navya Nyāya tradition, following Gaṅgeśa, analyses pratyakṣa as itself a complex cognitive achievement involving samskāra (traces of prior cognition) and the construction of perceptual content through multiple cognitive operations.

The anumāna (inference) in Dr. Prasad's poetry is the movement from specific observation to general insight: from the particular flood-ravaged village to the general condition of Maithili life; from the specific factionalism of the literary field to the general operation of caste-based hierarchy. The poem's argumentative structure, when it has one, is inferential in this Nyāya sense.

The śabda pramāṇa — verbal testimony — is the poet's relationship to the Maithili literary tradition itself: to Vidyapati, to the charyapadas, to Harimohan Jha, to the folk songs. Dr. Prasad's poems are in dialogue with this tradition; they cite it, contest it, and draw authority from it.

### *5.2.2 Viṣayatā and Svarūpa: The Object of Poetic Cognition*

Gaṅgeśa's analysis of viṣayatā — the mode in which a cognition is "directed toward" or "takes as object" a particular thing — is applicable to the theory of poetic reference. What does a poem "take as object"? In Dr. Prasad's work, the objects of poetic cognition are multiple and simultaneous: the visible landscape of Mithila, the felt experience of linguistic identity, the memory of the literary tradition, the social pain of caste and poverty, and the philosophical-spiritual dynamic of rāga-virāga.

Navya Nyāya's concept of avacchedaka (limitor, or the condition that "delimits" a cognition) is useful for analysing how the poem specifies its object. In Rag-Virag, the poems specify their objects through the limitor of the rāga-virāga dialectic: every image, every observation, every social critique is limited or specified by this philosophical framework. The flood is not just a flood; it is an image delimited by the avacchedaka of virāga — the detachment that perceives the flood not with panic but with the equanimity of one who has understood impermanence.

### *5.2.3 Pakṣatā: The Condition of the Subject of Inference*

Gaṅgeśa's analysis of pakṣatā — the condition that must obtain in the subject of a Nyāya inference for the inference to be valid — can be applied to the social conditions of poetic production. For an inference (or a poem) to be valid, the

"subject" (the poet, the voice) must be properly situated with respect to the claim being made.

Applied to Dr. Prasad's work, this becomes an analysis of his social positioning as a poet. He writes as an insider to the Mithila experience — pakṣatā is established. But he also writes as a critical intellectual who has been trained in the traditions of the Maithili literary academy — this dual positioning generates the productive tension between folk authenticity and critical self-consciousness that characterises his poetry.

The suppression of Gaṅgeśa's cross-caste marriage in the dominant scholarly tradition is itself a violation of pakṣatā: the Brahmin scholars who suppressed this fact were not proper subjects for making claims about Gaṅgeśa's biography, because their caste interest distorted their cognition. The Videha Parallel History, by recovering the suppressed biographical fact from the Panji records, restores the conditions for valid cognition (pramā) about Gaṅgeśa's life.

### *5.2.4 Anyathāsiddhi and Literary Fallacies*

Navya Nyāya devotes extensive analysis to the conditions under which inference fails — including anyathāsiddhi, where the conclusion is explained by a different cause than the one cited. Applied to literary criticism, this becomes a theory of critical fallacy: when a critical claim about a poem is "explained" by a factor other than the poem's actual features.

The mainstream literary establishment's neglect of writers like Dr. Prasad is an example of anyathāsiddhi in critical practice: when a poem is dismissed not because of its actual literary qualities but because of the social location (caste, region, publishing network) of its author, the critical "inference" (this is minor work) is anyathāsiddha — explained by a different, illegitimate cause.

Navya Nyāya's insistence on proper vyāpti (invariable concomitance) — the legitimate inferential relation between reason and conclusion — demands that literary criticism demonstrate the proper relation between the textual evidence and the critical judgment. This is precisely what the Parallel History's method insists on: close reading of the actual texts, not evaluation by proxy of the author's social position.

# VI. COMPARATIVE LITERARY PERSPECTIVES

## 6.1 Dr. Prasad in the Context of Contemporary Maithili Poetry

Contemporary Maithili poetry — as documented in the Videha Parallel History — is a diverse field that includes the ghazal revival (the Anchinhar Aakhar movement), Dalit Maithili poetry, women's Maithili poetry (the "Stri Kona" tradition), and the diaspora voices of Maithili speakers in Nepal, Delhi, and the international Maithili diaspora.

Within this landscape, Dr. Prasad's work is notable for its sustained philosophical depth — the engagement with rāga-virāga as a structuring philosophical framework — combined with its social groundedness. This distinguishes him from poets who are primarily lyric-experiential (like Arvind Thakur, the "free-spirited voice" discussed in Parallel History Part 34) and from those who are primarily social-documentary.

His relationship to the Vidyapatian lyric tradition is also significant. Vidyapati's poetry — the devotional-erotic Maithili padavali addressed to Radha-Krishna — is the canonical achievement of medieval Maithili literature. Contemporary Maithili poets must position themselves in relation to this tradition: to imitate it is to court pastiche; to ignore it is to sever roots. Dr. Prasad's approach — absorbing the philosophical and lyrical resources of the tradition while redirecting them toward contemporary social concerns — represents a mature negotiation.

## 6.2 Parallels with Kabir and the Sant Tradition

The Videha Parallel History's recovery of Kabir's Maithili padas — documented by Kamala Kant Bhandari and Subhadra Jha — establishes a democratic-spiritual strand in Maithili literature that runs parallel to (and in tension with) the Brahmin-centred court tradition. Kabir's anti-caste spirituality, his use of vernacular folk idiom, his paradoxical and ironic poetic mode — these are the aesthetic resources of the Maithili parallel tradition.

Dr. Prasad's virāga has Kabiresque resonances: the renunciation of false social identities, the insistence on the unmediated experience of reality, the mistrust of institutional religion and literary hierarchy simultaneously. The rāga-virāga dialectic in his work is not the court-Vaishnava rāga-virāga of longing and detachment from the beloved; it is closer to Kabir's ulṭā bhāī — the upside-down world where the socially marginalised speak truth to the powerful.

### 6.3 Comparison with Global Minor Literature

Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari's concept of "minor literature" — as exemplified in their study of Kafka — is illuminating for Dr. Prasad's work. Minor literature is not the literature of a minor language, but literature that a minority makes in a major language — or, in the extended sense, literature produced from a position of social marginality within any linguistic field. Its characteristics include the deterritorialisation of language (making the dominant language strange, inadequate), the immediate connection of the individual to political concerns, and the collective enunciation that speaks for a people not yet constituted.

Dr. Prasad's Maithili is already technically a "minor" language in relation to Hindi. But within Maithili itself, his work functions as minor literature in Deleuze-Guattari's sense: it deterritorialises the dominant Maithili literary language (the Brahmin high-register poetry of the academy), makes it strange and inadequate for contemporary Maithili social reality, and speaks in a collective voice that constitutes, rather than reflects, a Maithili literary community.

The Welsh poet R.S. Thomas offers another comparative perspective: Thomas's sustained commitment to Welsh cultural identity, his poetry of rural landscape and social transformation, his sense of being the last guardian of a threatened language and culture — these resonate with Dr. Prasad's position as a Maithili poet committed to a language whose speakers are dispersed, institutionally marginalised, and internally divided.

## VII. FORMAL AND STYLISTIC ANALYSIS

### 7.1 Prosody and Metre

Maithili lyric poetry has a rich prosodic heritage. The classical tradition uses mātrik (moraically counted) metres inherited from Sanskrit through Apabhraṃśa and Avahatta. The Vidyapatian padavali uses specific metres associated with particular ragas — the connection between lyric metre and musical mode (rāga) is structurally significant.

The title Rag-Virag itself invokes this metrical-musical heritage: each poem in the rāga-virāga tradition was historically sung in a specific rāga. Dr. Prasad's contemporary use of the term invokes this tradition while also liberating it from its strictly musical context: his "rāgas" are emotional and philosophical states,

not musical modes, though the aesthetic resonance of the musical connection enriches the reading.

Contemporary Maithili poetry has moved between strict traditional metres and free verse (mukt chhand), following the influence of Hindi chhāyāvāda and pragativāda poetry from the early twentieth century. Dr. Prasad's prosodic practice reflects this modernity: he uses both structured and freer forms, with the choice of form itself carrying meaning.

## 7.2 Imagery and Symbolism

Dr. Prasad's imagery is drawn from three primary reservoirs: the natural world of Mithila (rivers, floods, agricultural seasons, birds, and the Maithili landscape), the social world of the Mithila community (markets, migration, kinship, domestic life), and the philosophical-devotional world of the classical tradition (the rāga-virāga dialectic, the motifs of Vaishnava and Shaiva devotion, the Kabir-tradition of paradox and irony).

The river — particularly the Kosi, the "sorrow of Bihar" — is a recurring symbolic complex in Maithili literature. The river gives life and destroys it; it connects and separates; it floods and withdraws. In the rāga-virāga framework, the river's seasonal attachment (its presence) and detachment (its withdrawal) is a natural emblem of the philosophical dialectic.

The hāṭ (market) of Manak Haat is not merely economic; it is social, epistemological, and aesthetic. The market is where values are established and contested, where the standard (mānak) is negotiated in practice, where the poem must earn its audience without institutional guarantee.

## 7.3 Intertextuality

Dr. Prasad's poetry is richly intertextual, drawing on the resources of the classical Maithili tradition (Vidyapati, the charyapadas), the Hindi modernist tradition (the chhāyāvāda poets — Nirala, Pant, Mahadevi Varma — who share some sensibility with the rāga-virāga philosophy), and the Sanskrit philosophical tradition (Vedanta, Navya Nyāya, Shaiva aesthetics). This intertextuality operates primarily through allusion, echo, and the philosophical vocabulary of the texts rather than through explicit citation.

The Bakhtinian concept of dialogism is useful here: Dr. Prasad's poems are in implicit dialogue with multiple prior voices — Vidyapati's bhakti lyrics, Kabir's anti-caste ultas, the Charyapada siddhas' coded mystical verse — without necessarily naming them. The dialogue is carried through shared vocabulary,

shared concerns, and the shared symbolic resources of the Maithili literary tradition.

# VIII. CRITICAL EVALUATION AND SIGNIFICANCE

## 8.1 Literary Achievements

Dr. Shiv Kumar Prasad's two collections, Manak Haat and Rag-Virag, represent a significant contribution to contemporary Maithili poetry on several counts. First, they demonstrate that the rāga-virāga philosophical framework — associated primarily with classical devotional poetry — can be productively reworked for contemporary social critique. This is not a minor achievement: it requires both philosophical depth and poetic craft to revivify a classical framework without merely reproducing it.

Second, the two collections taken together trace an aesthetic development from the democratising-market energy of Manak Haat (2021) to the more philosophically concentrated and socially explicit pain of Rag-Virag (2024). The three years between them mark a deepening of both social analysis and philosophical reflection.

Third, Dr. Prasad's consistent commitment to Maithili as the language of serious literary production — his refusal of the Hindi or English option — is an intellectual and political act of considerable significance in the context of the ongoing struggle for Maithili's linguistic dignity.

## 8.2 Areas for Further Scholarly Attention

Several aspects of Dr. Prasad's work merit further scholarly investigation. The first is a comprehensive analysis of his prosodic practice: a systematic study of the metres he employs, their relationship to the classical Maithili metrical heritage, and the semantic effects of his formal choices.

The second is a study of his specific engagement with Maithili folk tradition — the relationship between his literary poetry and the oral-folk genres (sohar, sumangali, jhumar, nachari) that constitute the deep substrate of Maithili literary culture. How does his poetry draw on, transform, and respond to these oral traditions?

The third is a comparative study of his work in relation to other contemporary Maithili poets published through the Videha ecosystem — Arvind Thakur, Rabindra Narayan Mishra, and others discussed in the Parallel History series — that would situate his work more precisely within the contemporary Maithili literary field.

### 8.3 Limitations and Challenges

Any critical appreciation of Dr. Prasad's work must acknowledge the structural challenges facing Maithili literary scholarship. The limited circulation of Maithili texts (Manak Haat at ₹175 and Rag-Virag at ₹290 from a regional press in Nirmali, Supaul) means that the academic reception of his work is necessarily limited. The absence of translations into major Indian or world languages means that his work is not accessible to the comparative literary community except through the mediation of scholars who read Maithili.

## IX. CONCLUSIONS

Dr. Shiv Kumar Prasad (Lavml) is a serious and accomplished Maithili poet whose two collections — Manak Haat (2021) and Rag-Virag (2024) — merit sustained critical attention. His work is simultaneously rooted in the classical philosophical and aesthetic resources of the Maithili-Mithila tradition and deeply engaged with the contemporary social, political, and linguistic concerns of the Maithili-speaking community.

Analysed through the multiple frameworks employed in this study — Rasaśāstra and Dhvani theory, New Criticism and cultural materialism, postcolonial theory and feminist criticism, the Videha Parallel History Framework, and Navya Nyāya epistemology — his poetry reveals a layered and philosophically sophisticated literary achievement. The rāga-virāga dialectic that structures Rag-Virag is particularly significant: it is both a classically grounded philosophical framework and a contemporary political statement about attachment and detachment from a language and culture under institutional threat.

Within the Videha Parallel History Framework, Dr. Prasad occupies a clear and important position: he is a democratic-lyric voice in the alternative canon that the Parallel History has been documenting since 2000 — a voice that belongs to the tradition running from the Buddhist Charyapada siddhas through Kabir's Maithili padas through Harimohan Jha's satirical humanism into the present. His publication through Pallavi Prakashan, Nirmali, and his archival presence

on the Videha platform, ensure that his work is preserved within this parallel literary heritage.

The Navya Nyāya analytical framework, applied to his poetry, reveals the epistemological seriousness of his project: his poems make genuine knowledge-claims about Maithili social reality, employing the pramāṇas of direct perception, inference, and literary tradition in a manner that can be subjected to rigorous epistemological scrutiny. The suppressed biography of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya — recovered by the Videha Parallel History from Dooshan Panji records — serves as a reminder that the conditions for valid cognition (pramā) are always also social and political conditions.

Finally, Dr. Prasad's work is significant as an act of commitment: the commitment to write in Maithili, to publish through independent regional infrastructure, to dedicate one's creative labour to the "linguistic interiority" of a language that has been repeatedly marginalised, instrumentalised, and fractured by factionalism. In the language of Navya Nyāya, this commitment is his pakṣatā — the condition that makes his poetic claims legitimate and his voice authoritative. In the language of the Parallel History, it is his membership of the democratic tradition. In the language of the rāga-virāga dialectic that gives his finest collection its name, it is the act of a poet who has chosen attachment — rāga — to Mithila and Maithili, while achieving the virāga — dispassion — to see them clearly.

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**ADDENDUM: 2**

**Socio-Cultural Realism and Linguistic Preservation: A Comprehensive Analysis of Dr. Shiv Kumar Prasad's Contributions to the Videha Maithili Archive**

The digital evolution of Maithili literature in the twenty-first century finds its most robust expression in the "Videha" e-journal, a platform that has transcended the traditional boundaries of regional publishing to create a global repository for the Mithila region's intellectual output. Within this expansive archive, the presence of Dr. Shiv Kumar Prasad signifies a pivotal shift in the Maithili literary canon—a move away from purely classical or hagiographic themes toward a grounded, visceral social realism. The works of Dr. Prasad, primarily concentrated in the "Videha Sadeha" series, offer a profound look into the infrastructure of daily life, the failings of public institutions, and the persistent cultural markers of North Bihar. This report provides an exhaustive examination of Dr. Prasad's literary footprint as documented on www.videha.co.in, analyzing his prose through the lenses of socio-political critique, regional identity, and linguistic modernization.

**The Structural Framework of Videha and the Sadeha Series**

To properly situate the research on Dr. Shiv Kumar Prasad, it is essential to understand the medium through which his work has been preserved. Videha, functioning as the first Maithili fortnightly e-journal (ISSN 2229-547X), operates under the editorial philosophy of "Manushimih Sanskritam," which emphasizes the cultivation of the human spirit through refined linguistic and cultural expression. Under the stewardship of Gajendra Thakur, the journal has moved beyond a simple publication to become a "petar" or a digital chest, housing the most significant prose and verse of the contemporary era.

Dr. Shiv Kumar Prasad's primary contributions are anthologized in "Videha Sadeha- 17," a curated collection of the e-journal. This volume is particularly noted for its editorial stance against falsehood, ego, and hypocrisy, suggesting that the authors included Prasad among them represent a moral and aesthetic

standard within the Maithili literary movement. His work includes both creative prose and potentially reflective essays.

| Administrative and Bibliographic Detail | Data Specification |
|---|---|
| Primary Archive Source | Videha Sadeha - 17 (Issues 169-190) |
| Journal ISSN | 2229-547X |
| Editorial Supervision | Gajendra Thakur |
| Primary Linguistic Script | Devanagari (with references to Tirhuta) |
| Publication Frequency | Fortnightly (1st and 15th of every month) |

The organization of the site into sections such as "Videha," "Pothi," and "Ratna" allows for a multi-layered understanding of Maithili scholarship.

Insights into the "Mithila Ratna"

The research into Dr. Shiv Kumar Prasad reveals that he is listed in the "Mithila Ratna" (Gems of Mithila) section. This section typically lists historical luminaries such as:Aryabhatta: The scientist whose lineage is traced through "Panji" records.Yajnavalkya: The ancient philosopher.Modern Giants: Such as Lili Ray (born 1933), the Sahitya Akademi winner.The fact that Dr. Prasad is featured in the "Sadeha" series and also in the "Ratna" section is a function of the archive's structure. The "Ratna" section appears to focus not only on established historical figures or those with major institutional awards, but also on the "Sadeha" series which is a "living" collection of contemporary voices. This suggests that Dr. Prasad is viewed as part of the "active" or "modern" front of the Maithili movement—a writer whose work has processed and engaged with by his peers.

**Bibliographic Inventory and Thematic Overview**

The archive identifies several specific titles authored by Dr. Shiv Kumar Prasad. These titles, when analyzed collectively, reveal a writer deeply concerned with the intersection of regional geography, domestic tradition, and the alienating effects of urbanization.

**Catalog of Primary Works**

The following table summarizes the identified titles by Dr. Shiv Kumar Prasad within the Videha Sadeha 17 collection.

| **Title (Maithili)** | **Literal Translation/Thematic Anchor** | **Narrative Focus** |
|---|---|---|
| Nirmalik Nirmalatame | In the Purity of Nirmali | Regional identity and the sanctity of the Koshi region. |
| Tai Kichhu Ne Kichhu Likhait Jau | So Keep Writing Something | A meta-narrative on the necessity of literary persistence. |
| Baua Ker Ubtan | Baua's Traditional Ointment | Domestic rituals, caregiving, and childhood memories. |
| Shahar O Gel..... | He Went to the City... | Migration, rural-urban transition, and its consequences. |
| Khebaiya | The Boatman / Oarsman | Riverine life, labor, and the navigation of social currents. |
| May Hamar Nav Kumbh Naheli | My Mother Bathed in the New Pot | Maternal motifs, ritual purity, and traditional practices. |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| Dekh Elaun Ham Patna | I Have Seen Patna | Observations of the state capital from a regional lens. |

**The Meta-Narrative of Literary Persistence**

The work "Tai Kichhu Ne Kichhu Likhait Jau" (So Keep Writing Something) serves as a philosophical foundation for Dr. Prasad’s presence in the archive. In the context of the Maithili language, which has historically struggled for institutional recognition and digital space, this title suggests a call to action. It reflects the broader "Videha Maithili Sahitya Andolan" (Videha Maithili Literature Movement), which posits that the survival of the language is contingent upon continuous, unpretentious production. This perspective aligns with the editorial vision that values works free from the "ego" of the traditional literary establishment, focusing instead on the honest documentation of human experience.

**Regional Identity and the Geography of the Koshi Division**

One of the most striking aspects of Dr. Prasad’s work is its geographical specificity. While much of classic Maithili literature is centered on the Darbhanga and Madhubani districts—the traditional cultural heartland—Dr. Prasad’s prose frequently pivots toward the Supaul, Saharsa, and Nirmali axis.

**The Purity of Nirmali**

The title "Nirmalik Nirmalatame" (In the Purity of Nirmali) suggests a deep connection to Nirmali, a significant town in the Supaul district. Historically, Nirmali has been a vital trade and transit point, but it is also a region defined by its relationship with the Koshi River, often referred to as the "Sorrow of Bihar." By emphasizing "Nirmalata" (purity), Prasad may be contrasting the intrinsic cultural value of this peripheral region with the perceived corruption or dilution of culture in larger urban centers. This regional pride is a recurring theme in the Videha archives, where authors seek to document the unique dialects and customs of different pockets of Mithila.

**Urbanization and Administrative Shifts**

In the descriptive prose sections associated with Dr. Prasad, there is a keen observation of the changing landscape of North Bihar. The narrative describes a journey from Saharsa where a scooter breaks down, leading to an enforced delay. This incident provides a window into the administrative evolution of the

region: the transition of a town from a "sub-division" (Anumandal) to a "district headquarters" (Jila Mukhyalaya).

| Geographical Point | Narrative Context in Prasad’s Work |
|---|---|
| Saharsa | Starting point of a journey; site of administrative flux. |
| Supaul | Destination; evolving from sub-division to district center. |
| Nirmali | Symbolic center of "purity" and regional identity. |
| Patna | The urban "other"; site of legal and political power. |

The text notes that with this change in administrative status, "the price of land has increased," suggesting a shift from an agrarian economy to one dominated by real estate and debt. Dr. Prasad’s narrative captures the anxiety of this transition, where characters are forced to sell land to settle "karja-barja" (debts), a stark reality for many families in the wake of Bihar’s changing economic policies.

**Social Realism and the Critique of Public Institutions**

Dr. Shiv Kumar Prasad’s prose stands out for its unflinching portrayal of the failures of the state machinery. Unlike the idealized depictions of Mithila found in historical or mythological texts, his stories navigate the "dust and smoke" of modern existence.

**The Judicial System and the Gopal-Chaturanan Conflict**

A significant portion of the narrative fragments in the archive details a conflict between characters named Gopal and Chaturanan. This narrative thread serves as a critique of the "Lathi" (stick) culture and the subsequent failure of the legal system to provide justice.

The incident begins with an act of violence: Chaturanan attacks Gopal with a "lathi" at a "pan-bala" (betel leaf) shop. The following developments illustrate the systemic rot:

1. **Police Corruption**: The narrative states that the police "collected money (pai) from Chaturanan," allowing him to remain comfortably at home while the victim suffered.
2. **Disappearance of Evidence**: Crucial evidence, specifically the "X-ray plates" documenting the injury, went missing from the hospital, likely due to institutional complicity.
3. **Judicial Inefficiency**: The legal proceedings are described as a series of "tarikh" (dates), extending over three years before testimony even begins.

Dr. Prasad uses the character of the lawyer (Vakeel) to highlight the transactional nature of justice. The lawyer is depicted as "cleaning his ear with the back of a pen" while ignoring his client, only giving priority to those who have paid more. This vivid, sensory detail—the "turshi" (sharpness or acidity) in the lawyer's voice—humanizes the systemic critique, making it a powerful piece of social commentary.

**Infrastructure and Technological Precariousness**

The breakdown of the scooter on the road from Saharsa is more than a plot point; it is a metaphor for the state of Bihar's infrastructure. The description of the mechanic opening "pat-purja" (spare parts) and leaving them scattered for four hours reflects a society where technology is present but the systems to maintain it are haphazard. The "roud, garda, aa dhua" (sun, dust, and smoke) of the highway provide a sensory backdrop to this struggle, emphasizing the physical toll that regional travel takes on the individual.

**Domesticity, Tradition, and the Maternal Motif**

While the social critique provides the "external" world of Dr. Prasad's prose, his "internal" world is defined by domesticity and traditional Maithili rituals. The titles "Baua Ker Ubtan" and "May Hamar Nav Kumbh Naheli" point toward this intimate sphere.

**The Symbolism of the Kumbh and Ubtan**

In Maithili culture, the "Kumbh" (pot) is a central element in various "Sanskaras" (life-cycle rituals). The "Nav Kumbh" (new pot) mentioned in the title suggests a ritual of purification or a new beginning, perhaps associated with a festival or a birth. Similarly, "Ubtan" is a traditional paste made of turmeric, mustard oil, and other ingredients, used for skin care and in pre-

wedding ceremonies. By titling his works with these terms, Dr. Prasad anchors his narrative in the sensory and tactile reality of Maithili life. This serves to preserve the "Nirmalata" (purity) he celebrates, even as the characters navigate the "dust" of the outside world.

**The Maternal Figure as Cultural Anchor**

The "May" (Mother) in Dr. Prasad's titles is not just a biological parent but a symbol of the land and tradition. This is a common trope in Maithili literature, but Prasad treats it with a specific realism. The mother "holding the earth" (dharati pakadi rahal chhathi) suggests a desperate attempt to maintain roots in the face of the "mahakal" (great death or time) of poverty and famine that often haunts the region.

**Urban Observation: "Dekh Elaun Ham Patna"**

The story or essay "Dekh Elaun Ham Patna" (I Have Seen Patna) represents the peak of the rural-urban tension in Prasad's work. For a resident of the Supaul-Saharsa region, Patna is not just the capital; it is a place of aspiration and alienation.

The narrative details of the court case and the hospital indicate that the city is often experienced through its cold, indifferent institutions—the high court, the large hospitals, and the administrative offices. Dr. Prasad's perspective is that of the outsider who "sees" Patna and reports back to the regional center. This "reporting" often involves a deconstruction of the city's glamour, focusing instead on the "transparency" of the struggles of the migrant.

**Comparative Analysis with Contemporary Maithili Scholars**

Dr. Shiv Kumar Prasad's work exists alongside a diverse array of scholars in the Videha archive. By comparing his output with others, we can better understand his specific niche.

| Scholar/Writer | Focus Area |
|---|---|
| **Dr. Shiv Kumar Prasad** | Social Realism, Infrastructure, Domestic Rituals |
| **Dr. Shankar Kumar Jha** | Political Analysis of Vidyapati |

| | |
|---|---|
| **Dr. Raman Jha** | Maithili Poetics and Linguistics |
| **Gajendra Thakur** | Language Education and Digital Archiving |
| **Dr. Shambhu Kumar Singh** | Selected Prose and Verse |

Unlike Dr. Shankar Kumar Jha, whose work is academic and focused on political history, or Dr. Raman Jha, who focuses on the mechanics of poetry (Alankara), Dr. Shiv Kumar Prasad is a chronicler of the present. His work is less about the "theory" of Maithili and more about the "practice" of being a Maithili speaker in a rapidly changing Bihar.

**Linguistic Style and the Devanagari-Tirhuta Dialectic**

The works of Dr. Prasad on the Videha site are primarily presented in the Devanagari script, which has become the pragmatically dominant script for Maithili in the modern era. However, the Videha journal itself is a major advocate for the Tirhuta (Mithilakshar) script, providing parallel versions of many texts.

Dr. Prasad’s prose style is characterized by:

- **Lexical Regionalism**: Using terms specific to the Koshi region (e.g., specific terms for agricultural tools or domestic rituals).
- **Narrative Fluidity**: Moving between the mundane (a broken scooter) and the profound (the failure of justice) without jarring transitions.
- **Satirical Undertones**: Particularly in his depiction of the professional classes (lawyers, police).

The archive also notes that the editor of Videha holds the rights for the "translation" of these works, suggesting that there is a recognized value in bringing Prasad’s Maithili prose to a broader, perhaps English-speaking or Hindi-speaking, audience.

**Implications for the Future of Maithili Literature**

The inclusion of Dr. Shiv Kumar Prasad’s work in the Videha archive has several long-term implications for the field of Maithili studies:

1. **Decentralization of the Canon**: By focusing on the Saharsa-Supaul region, Prasad’s work challenges the Darbhanga-centric view of Maithili culture, providing a more geographically inclusive literary map.

2. **Digital-First Preservation**: His presence in an e-journal that prioritizes "freedom from ego" suggests that the future of minority language literature lies in digital spaces that are accessible to the global diaspora.
3. **The Rise of Social Realism**: His focus on the "failed state" and infrastructure provides a model for younger Maithili writers to move beyond nostalgia and engage with the political realities of North Bihar.

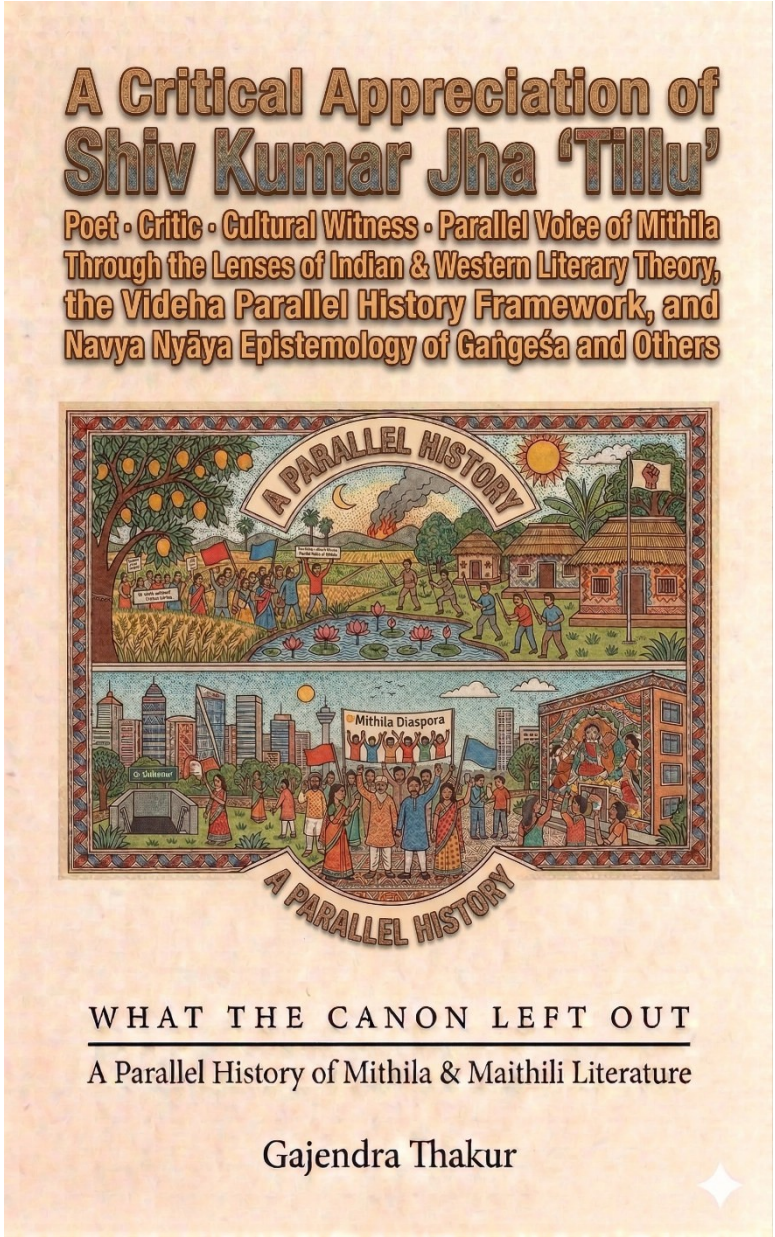
**Qualitative Synthesis of Prasad's Literary Impact**

In summarizing the contributions of Dr. Shiv Kumar Prasad based on the Videha archives, we find a writer who serves as a bridge. He bridges the gap between the domestic ritual (the "Ubtan") and the public infrastructure (the "broken scooter"). He bridges the gap between the regional town (Nirmali) and the state capital (Patna). And most importantly, he bridges the gap between the classical tradition of Maithili scholarship and the urgent needs of modern social realism.

His prose does not merely describe the life of a Maithili speaker; it interrogates the conditions of that life. Whether he is describing the "transparency" of the migrant's struggle or the "sharpness" of a corrupt lawyer's voice, Prasad's work is a testament to the power of regional literature to act as a mirror to society. Within the "petar" of Videha, his contributions ensure that the "purity of Nirmali" is not just a memory, but a documented, living reality for future generations of the Mithila region.

Dr. Prasad's literary output, of the seventeenth "Sadeha" volume, remains a cornerstone for anyone seeking to understand the socio-political undercurrents of contemporary Mithila. His works are not just stories; they are ethnographic and sociological snapshots of a society navigating the complex waters of the twenty-first century, much like the "Khebaiya" (boatman) who navigates the unpredictable currents of the Koshi.

**LESSON 083 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**



*A Critical Appreciation of*

# Shiv Kumar Jha 'Tillu'

*Poet · Critic · Cultural Witness · Parallel Voice of Mithila*

Through the Lenses of Indian & Western Literary Theory, the Videha Parallel History Framework, and Navya Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa and Others

## Preface: The Momentary Flash That Illuminates

Kṣaṇaprabhā — the flash of lightning, the momentary brilliance — is a title that reveals its author's self-awareness with disarming clarity. Shiv Kumar Jha 'Tillu', who chooses this name for his first poetry collection, acknowledges that he is no 'natural poet' (naisargik kavi, as he writes in his own preface) but one in whose consciousness feeling crystallises into verse at particular charged instants. Yet it is precisely this honest, un-inflated self-presentation that distinguishes him from the pretensions of official literary culture, and that places him, unmistakably, within the Videha Parallel History tradition of writers who measure themselves not by institutional honour but by the sincerity of their engagement with language and life.

This critical appreciation examines Tillu's dual contribution to Maithili letters — as lyric poet in Kṣaṇaprabhā (2012) and as critic in Aṃśu (2013) — across several intersecting analytical frameworks: the Indian aesthetic traditions of rasa, dhvani, and aucitya; western critical paradigms from New Criticism and reader-response theory to postcolonial and subaltern studies; the Videha Parallel History Framework of Gajendra Thakur; and the rigorous epistemological method of Navya Nyāya as practised by Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya and the Mithila philosophical school. These frameworks are not applied in sequence as separable instruments but allowed to speak to and with each other, producing a multi-perspectival critical account that honours the complexity of the work.

# I. Biographical and Socio-Literary Context

## I.1 Life and Formation

Shiv Kumar Jha 'Tillu' was born on 11 December 1973 in Malipur Mohtar (his maternal village), Begusarai district, Bihar. His father is the late Kalikant Jha 'Buch' — himself a significant figure in Maithili poetry, whose verses appeared in Mithila Mihir and other respected journals, and who is acknowledged in the Sahitya Akademi's own anthology Samakaalin Maithili Kavita (compiled by Bhimnath Jha and Mohan Bhardwaj) as a notable poet of the mid-twentieth century. His mother was the late Chandrakala Devi, who also composed Maithili verse. Tillu's childhood nickname was given to him by his father's close friend, the mahakavi Fazlur Rehman Hashmi, Maithili poet. Hasmi Ji had named him Tillu. 'Fazlur Rahman Hasmi' Saheb used to stay with the physician (Vaidya) in Malipur during Shi Kumar Jha’s matriculation, back when he was a teacher at the village school. He would sing to the child: ‘Tillu Miyan raji, pet me karaji, aur daudo hau sipahi'- a formative detail that locates the poet within a web of literary and affective bonds from infancy.

His home village of Kariyan, Samastipur district, is situated in the geographic and cultural heartland of Mithila — the ancient region of Udayanacharyya, the great Nyāya philosopher, who was Gaṅgeśa's own forerunner. This connection — between the birthplace of Navya Nyāya and the childhood ground of Tillu — is not merely geographical coincidence; it points to a living intellectual environment in which philosophical rigour and literary sensibility have historically coexisted. After completing his graduation with distinction, Tillu settled in Jamshedpur where he worked with M/s J.M.A. STORES PRIVATE LTD (a Channel Partner of Tata Motors); he was with them from 2002 to 2022. Since 2023, he has been working with their sister concern company, Viniyog Capital (an NBFC that provides MSME loans). This detail underscores his position as a writer operating entirely outside the academic and institutional frameworks within which most 'recognised' Maithili writers have been based.

From 1996 to 2002, Tillu was actively involved in the cultural activities and Maithili promotion work of the Vidyapati Parishad, Samastipur, under the leadership of Dr. Naresh Kumar Vikal and Shri Uday Narayan Chaudhary (a National President Award-winning teacher). This period of organised cultural engagement shaped his understanding of Maithili's social situation — its vulnerability under Hindi-belt standardisation, its contested claims to institutional recognition, and the importance of grassroots cultural activism.

## I.2 Literary Inheritance: Kalikant Jha 'Buch' and the Family Tradition

The literary inheritance Tillu carries is specific and traceable. His father Kalikant Jha 'Buch' appears in Anshu's own preface as the one whose departure Tillu mourns — the dedication of Kṣaṇaprabhā is 'to the cherished memory of my paternal uncle, the late Navalakant Jha.' The double literary lineage — a father who was a poet and an uncle whose memory consecrates his first verse collection — places Tillu in the Maithili tradition of family-mediated literary formation, a tradition that extends from Vidyapati's relationship to his father Ganapati to the more recent familial literary environments documented in the parallel history.

What is distinctive about Tillu's inheritance is that it comes from a writer (Kalikant Jha 'Buch') who was himself excluded from the Sahitya Akademi anthology despite the quality of his work — a fact Tillu notes in Aṃśu with carefully restrained critical precision. By naming his father's exclusion from the 1988 anthology of 'Samakaalin Maithili Kavita' (which claims to represent the period 1961-1980), Tillu performs a filial act that is simultaneously a critical act: he insists that the canon is not the totality of the tradition, that what has been excluded has value, and that the critic's function includes recovering the excluded. None of the poems written by his father are included in any Contemporary Maithili Poetry anthologies. His name is only mentioned in a few anthologies.

## I.3 The Videha Connection

Tillu's critical journey began in Videha — the online Maithili journal founded by Gajendra Thakur that has since 2008 operated as the primary institutional vehicle of the Parallel Maithili literary tradition. As Tillu himself records in the Aṃśu preface, his critical writing started in Videha's feedback column (Feedback Column), where he posted online reviews of Maithili works. Over time, under the encouragement of editor Gajendra Thakur and co-editor Dr. Umesh Mandal, these occasional online responses developed into sustained critical essays that were eventually gathered and published as Aṃśu by Shruti Prakashan, Delhi — the same press that published Kṣaṇaprabhā, and whose

distributors are Pallavi Distributors, Nirmali (Supaul) — the small-town distribution network of the parallel Maithili movement.

Typesetting of Aṃśu was carried out by Umesh Mandal personally — a detail that, again, reflects the self-reliant, community-embedded institutional practice of the parallel literary world. The acknowledgement in Aṃśu's preface names Gajendra Thakur, Ravibhushan Pathak, and Satyanarayana Jha as the mentors who guided the 'handful of tears-flowers' (anjuri bhari kanail ka phool) toward publication. These are not pro-forma acknowledgements but markers of an actual literary community — one that operates outside the Sahitya Akademi circuit and its tributary networks.

[1] Shiv Kumar Jha 'Tillu', Kṣaṇaprabhā (Shruti Prakashan, 2012), Preface (Āmukh), p.5.

[2] Shiv Kumar Jha 'Tillu', Aṃśu (Shruti Prakashan, 2013), Preface (Āmukh), pp. 9-10.

[3] Biographical note, Kṣaṇaprabhā, p. 102.

## II. Kṣaṇaprabhā (2012): A Reading of the Poetry

### II.1 The Collection in Overview

Kṣaṇaprabhā (ISBN 978-93-80538-32-7, Shruti Prakashan, 2012, Rs. 200) is Tillu's debut poetry collection, gathering verse in multiple forms: traditional Maithili gīt (song-poems), shorter lyric poems, poems on seasonal and ecological themes, social satire, haiku, and two ghazals. The collection spans love lyrics in the viraha (separation) mode, festive poems on Holi, Chaita, and the seasonal cycle, meditations on social decay and cultural loss, politically charged verses on caste and agrarian injustice, environmental lament, and formal experiments in haiku and ghazal. This formal range is itself significant: it suggests a poet who is testing the limits of available Maithili verse forms rather than settling into a single mode.

The collection's typography and typesetting (carried out by Ashish Chaudhary, unlike Aṃśu which was typeset by Umesh Mandal) reflects the modest production values of the parallel publishing circuit, but the range and ambition

of the verse transcend any material limitations. The book is dedicated to the memory of 'Chhotaka Kakka' — the late Navalakant Jha — a dedication that anchors the verse in familial memory and makes the collection itself an act of elegy as much as creative self-expression.

## II.2 Rasa, Bhāva, and the Lyric Tradition

The dominant rasa of Kṣaṇaprabhā is a complex interweaving of śṛṅgāra (erotic-romantic sentiment) in its vipralambha (viraha, separation) mode and karuṇa (pathos, compassion). The opening poem 'Ṛtucakra mein Virahinī' ('The Lovelorn Woman in the Wheel of Seasons') established this register immediately: the beloved's question — 'Piya kona kai bitaitai Phaagun maas apar au, / Jīvan bhayal pahāḍ au na...' ('How will the beloved endure this boundless Phagun month? Life has become a mountain, beloved...') — positions viraha not as individual romantic loss but as a condition embedded in the cyclical pressures of the seasonal world. The koel's call, the bee's drone, the spring blossoms: all become instruments of heightened longing, the natural world conspiring against the isolated self.

This deployment of the viraha mode connects Tillu to the deepest roots of the Maithili lyric tradition — specifically to Vidyapati's padāvalī, where the love of Radha and Krishna is the vehicle for an exploration of longing, union, and the intensification of feeling through separation. Tillu is self-consciously working within this tradition while modernising its emotional vocabulary. His viraha poems are not court poetry but the articulation of ordinary longing — the separated couple of the contemporary Maithili world, where migration (padain) is the new form of separation that extends the classical viraha into the social present.

Applied through the lens of Bharata's Nāṭyaśāstra, the āyoga-vipralambha (separation before union) structuring many of Tillu's love poems creates the conditions for the heightened rasa-experience that the classical aesthetician describes: the stāyibhāva (dominant emotion) of rati (love) is intensified by the vyabhicāribhāvas (transitory emotions) of yearning (cintā), recollection (smṛti), and anxiety (śaṅkā), producing the full-blown rasa of śṛṅgāra in its most affecting form.

## II.3 Dhvani and the Unsaid

Several poems in Kṣaṇaprabhā operate with the suggestive indirection that Ānandavardhana's Dhvanyāloka identifies as the highest mode of poetic meaning. The poem 'Atṛpta Nayan' ('Unsatisfied Eyes') is emblematic: the speaker, waiting through a sleepless night, watches the beloved who has fallen asleep. The final question — 'Ahūñ ahinā karab ki?' ('Will you too not be with me?') — operates at multiple levels simultaneously: the surface level (the sleepless lover's plea), the personal-philosophical level (the question of mortality and abandonment), and the social level (the woman in patriarchal marriage who is perpetually 'unsatisfied' — her desires unacknowledged, her gaze unanswered). This layering of suggestion, where the words carry far more than their literal meaning, is the dhvani mode at work.

The haiku sequence in Kṣaṇaprabhā is another site of dhvani-practice. The compression of the haiku form — its radical economy — forces a kind of productive obscurity: the poem means through what it leaves out as much as through what it says. Tillu's adaptation of the Japanese haiku into Maithili creates a formally hybrid space where classical Maithili syllabic patterns interact with the imagistic discipline of the haiku tradition. Consider a sample haiku: 'Jaatee-pajaatek gethem / ojhara kai Maithilee / bhai gail bail nimool' — 'Tangled in the knot of caste-subcaste / Maithili / has become a homeless waif.' The three-line structure moves from sociological observation to linguistic fact to metaphorical consequence, with a formal economy that enacts the dispossession it describes.

## II.4 Social Poetry: Caste, Ecology, and Cultural Loss

Beyond the lyric poems, Kṣaṇaprabhā contains a significant body of social verse — poems addressing caste discrimination, ecological destruction, the loss of Maithili cultural memory, and the condition of the Maithili-speaking migrant. The long poem 'Sudhar' ('Reform') is among the most ambitious: a satirical-elegiac meditation on the contradictions of 'development' in the Maithila region. The poem catalogues the failures of scientific modernity — chemical agriculture destroying the soil, plastic replacing traditional materials, the Green Revolution's promises unfulfilled, the monsoon disrupted by global warming — while simultaneously mourning the loss of traditional ecological knowledge:

*'Aajuk rasaayansan maatik koti ujal / Thuth daant kinhu nai majal / Plastic chhori liau joota bora / Polythin nai thonga-jhora...' ('Today's chemicals have gutted the soil's soul / Nothing's grown strong in this age / Discard plastic, bring back the jute bag / No polythen, use the old cloth wrapper...')*

The environmental critique here operates at the intersection of ecology and culture: it is not merely the chemical contamination of the soil that the poem mourns, but the displacement of a whole system of material practice — jute bags, earthen pots, traditional medicines — by the disposable plasticity of consumer modernity. This is what Lawrence Buell's ecocriticism would call 'place-specificity' — the ecological imagination that is inseparable from a specific, named, culturally embedded landscape.

The poems about caste — 'Dwijak murhaiaya sangsang / Achop sooti kahit' ('The thread of the twice-born, alongside / the untouchable's blood flowing...') — deploy a bitter, condensed irony that recalls the dalit literary tradition's refusal of euphemism. Tillu is not writing as a dalit but as a member of the Brahmin community (his family name Jha identifies him as Maithil Brahmin) who is turning the tools of his literary inheritance against its social assumptions — a position of internal critique that parallels the tradition of Harimohan Jha, whose anti-caste satire the Videha Parallel History identifies as the most significant and most institutionally suppressed voice in 20th-century Maithili literature.

## II.5 Seasonal and Festive Poetry: Aucitya and Cultural Memory

A substantial portion of Kṣaṇaprabhā is devoted to the seasonal and festive cycle of Maithil life: Holi, Chaita, Ṛtucakra (the wheel of seasons), Basant (spring), Sharad (autumn). These poems are formally the most traditional in the collection — they employ the gīt form with its refrains, its call-and-response structures, and its direct connection to the oral-performative tradition of Maithili folk song. The Holi poems ('Navaturiya Holi', 'Dori', 'Holi') reconstruct the festival not as generic celebration but as a specific, named, socially textured event: particular characters, particular village spaces, particular smells and colours.

Kṣemendra's concept of aucitya (propriety, appropriateness) — the principle that each poetic element must be appropriate to its context, its genre, its emotional register, and its moment — is precisely what these poems embody. The Holi poem employs the dholak-duggi rhythm that belongs to Holi; the

viraha poems use the koel's call that belongs to spring's intensification; the ecological poems use a satirical velocity that belongs to political verse. Each poem knows what it is doing and does it with the right tools. This is aucitya as structural intelligence, not merely as decorum.

The Chaita poem 'Chaitaavar' ('The Chaita Song') is particularly notable: it reconstructs the specific musical and social geography of Chaita performance — the spring song tradition of Mithila, associated with the Holi season and the full flowering of spring — with an attention to detail (the male singing groups, the drumming, the scent of flowers, the festival of Shivaratri) that transforms a short lyric into a cultural archive. For the reader who knows this tradition, the poem is densely resonant; for the reader who does not, it opens a window onto a world of practice whose preservation in written form is itself a political act.

## II.6 The Ghazals: Formal Hybridity and the Tradition of Mithila

Kṣaṇaprabhā concludes with two ghazals — a formal choice that connects Tillu to one of the most interesting developments in contemporary Maithili literature: the Anchinhar Aakhar movement for the revitalisation of the Maithili ghazal, documented in Part 4 of the Videha Parallel History. The ghazal form carries its own tradition of the beloved's absence and the lover's wandering — a tradition rooted in Persian and Urdu literary cultures that has been adapted into multiple Indian languages. In Tillu's hands, the ghazal becomes a vehicle for meditation on cultural and spiritual darkness:

*'Kaaraatrikame mahmi dinman kona aayat / monme paap jharal bhagavan kona aayat' ('How can the daylight come in the black night? / With sin in the heart, how can God arrive?')*

The ghazal's radif-maqtā structure — the repeated refrain and the signature couplet — disciplines the emotional content into formal containment, creating the tension between overflow and form that the best ghazal achieves. Tillu's signature in the maqtā ('Tillu' appearing in the final couplet) follows the classical convention while localising it in the Maithili context. The second ghazal shifts from the spiritual-personal to the social-political, meditating on the failures of communal harmony and the betrayals of institutional religion:

*'Sohaait nai budi sargam samajak das parilaksit / sunait di bhaelak kaal gati gaharait nai vikal jivan' ('The scale of social slavery cannot be heard rightly / Time's momentum deepens but cannot shake the anguished life')*

This social ghazal, with its critique of compromise (the word 'compromise' itself appears in Devanagari transliteration in the haiku section — 'Kompromais karait rahal / kono kalush kompromais nai' — marking the contamination of the social world by imported vocabulary and values), extends the ghazal's traditional lament into a sharply contemporary political register.

## III. Aṃśu (2013): Critical Studies in Maithili Literature

### III.1 Overview and Critical Method

Aṃśu ('Tear-drops' or 'Portions of Sunlight' — the word carries both meanings in Maithili) is a collection of thirty-four critical essays on Maithili literature, published by Shruti Prakashan, Delhi in 2013 (ISBN 978-93-80538-33-4, Rs. 100, typeset by Umesh Mandal). The collection is dedicated to the memory of Tillu's parents — his mother Chandrakala Devi and his father Kalikant Jha 'Buch.' The range of the critical essays is extraordinary: they cover Dalit representation in Maithili fiction, surveys of contemporary Maithili poetry, detailed reviews of specific literary works (novels, plays, poetry collections, children's literature), assessments of individual writers' contributions to the development of particular genres, and reflections on the relationship between Maithili language survival and literary production.

The preface to Aṃśu is itself a critical document of some importance. It articulates Tillu's theory of samālocanā (critical appreciation as opposed to mere ālocanā or criticism): where European literary criticism (he translates 'criticism' as 'criticism') has a reputation for negative evaluation, Tillu argues that samālocanā must examine a work from all ten directions (daso disasse) — not merely from the outside (chāru kāt se dekhab, 'looking from the four sides') but from within, comprehensively, with the intent of understanding and enhancing creative vitality rather than diminishing it. This is a theory of criticism as affirmative engagement — closer to the Navya Nyāya ideal of pramā (valid knowledge arrived at through multiple pramāṇas) than to the adversarial model implicit in much Western critical discourse.

## III.2 Dalit Representation in Maithili Fiction: The Opening Essay

The opening essay of Aṃśu — 'Maithili Upanyaas Sahityame Dalit Patron ka Chitran' ('The Depiction of Dalit Characters in Maithili Novel Literature') — is the most ambitious and politically significant piece in the collection. It surveys the major Maithili novelists from Jansīdan (the first recognised Maithili novelist) through Harimohan Jha, Yatri (Nagarjun), Lalita, Manimap (Manipadma), Shefali Varma, Jagdish Prasad Mandal, and Gajendra Thakur, examining the presence and nature of Dalit characters in each writer's fiction.

The essay's key critical finding is both obvious in retrospect and devastating in its implications: despite the fact that Dalits constitute approximately eight annas (half) of Mithila's population, and despite the fact that their mother tongue is Maithili, the tradition of Maithili fiction has largely treated Dalit characters as accidental presences (akasmāt ayyāgat, 'unexpected visitors') rather than subjects with their own interiority, agency, and narrative centrality. Only Jagdish Prasad Mandal's fiction — above all in Maulail Gachhak Phool — is identified as offering genuinely full-dimensional Dalit characterisation, where the lives, choices, and moral complexity of Dalit characters are rendered with the same seriousness as those of upper-caste characters.

From the perspective of postcolonial subaltern studies — specifically Gayatri Spivak's reformulation of the question of subaltern voice and representation — Tillu's critical essay performs the crucial task of identifying structural absences in a literary tradition. The Maithili novel's failure to represent Dalits is not merely an aesthetic failure but a political one: it reflects and reproduces the social invisibility that structures the Dalit experience in Mithila. By naming this failure systematically, across the full span of the novelistic tradition, Tillu's criticism enacts what Spivak calls 'strategic essentialism' — an insistence on naming the group that has been excluded as a necessary first step toward inclusion.

The essay's treatment of Gajendra Thakur's Sahasrashīrṣā is particularly revealing: Tillu notes that this massive novel — one of the foundational texts of the Videha Parallel History — provides the most comprehensive literary mapping of Dalit communities in Mithila, naming and distinguishing multiple distinct communities (the washermen, the cobblers, the Dom, the Dusadh, the Musahar, the Paswan), giving each their specific social location, their occupational identity, their residential topology in the village, and — crucially — their trajectories of change in contemporary India. This is literature as social cartography, and Tillu's critical account of it is among the most detailed and appreciative passages in Aṃśu.

## III.3 The Critique of the Sahitya Akademi Anthology

The second essay of Aṃśu — a review of the Sahitya Akademi's 1988 anthology Samakaalin Maithili Kavita (Contemporary Maithili Poetry, edited by Bhimnath Jha and Mohan Bhardwaj, covering the period 1961-1980) — is a model of what the Videha Parallel History calls 'epistemic critique': the systematic examination of a canonical text to expose the exclusions and distortions that constitute its claim to representativeness.

Tillu's critique is precise and evidence-based. He notes that the anthology includes 21 poets and 68 poems, covering a twenty-year period — but that within this selection, some poets receive disproportionate representation (Mayanand receives five poems; others, only one or two) while significant poets are entirely excluded. Among those excluded: the women poets Shefali Varma (whose collection Vipralabdhā was published in 1974, within the anthology's timeframe), Subhadra Singh Padhya, Shyama Devi, and Ila Rani Singh; the poets Gopesh, Fazlur Rahman Hashmi, Chandabhanu Singh, Vilat Paswan 'Vihangam' (a significant dalit voice); and — most notably — Kalikant Jha 'Buch', Tillu's own father, whose poems on politics, social life, and cultural protest appeared regularly in Mithila Mihir throughout the covered period.

Significantly, Tillu does not attribute the exclusions to deliberate prejudice — he notes explicitly that he does not accuse the editorial board of pūrvāgraha (predetermined bias). He offers the editors the charitable assumption that there may have been unavoidable circumstances. But the pattern of the exclusions speaks for itself: women poets, dalit poets, and poets whose social criticism was too sharp for the conservative mainstream were systematically missed. The anthology's claim to represent 'contemporary Maithili poetry' is therefore structurally false — it represents a portion of the tradition, selected through filters that reflect the social and aesthetic preferences of its editors.

Applying the Navya Nyāya concept of anumāna (inference) here: from the evidence of the exclusions, we can infer the selection principle; from the selection principle, we can infer the social world that produced it. The anthology is thus not merely an aesthetic document but an epistemological one — a knowledge-claim about Maithili literature that, under scrutiny, turns out to be a viparīta-jñāna (inverted knowledge), a false picture of the tradition's actual range and vitality.

## III.4 The Reviews of Individual Works: Critical Range and Method

The bulk of Aṃśu consists of individual reviews of Maithili literary works — novels, plays, poetry collections, children's literature, and hybrid forms. The range of works reviewed is itself a statement about the parallel tradition's scope and ambition: Tillu reviews not only the canonical 'big names' but also less-known but significant works, recent publications, and — crucially — works by writers from outside the Maithil Brahmin mainstream (Jagdish Prasad Mandal, Rajdeo Mandal, Vibha Rani, Preeti Thakur, among others).

The review of Jagdish Prasad Mandal's Maulail Gachhak Phool (essay 5) is among the most sustained and appreciative in the collection. Tillu's analysis proceeds through the narrative structure (the progressive revelation of social solidarity against feudal oppression), the characterisation (the Musahar family of Rohagi, Bagagba, and Kabuteri as centres of consciousness rather than objects of sympathy), the language (Mandal's use of the spoken Maithili of the working poor, uncontaminated by literary archaisms), and the social vision (the novel's insistence that Mithila's renewal requires the full incorporation of its most marginalised people into the project of collective life). The review reads Mandal as what Tillu calls 'sarvakaalin Maithili sahityame Dhruvatara' — the pole star of all-time Maithili literature — a judgment that aligns with and reinforces the Videha Parallel History's positioning of Mandal as the most significant contemporary Maithili novelist.

The review of Vibha Rani's play Balchanda (essay 7) demonstrates Tillu's capacity for feminist critical reading: he analyses the play's feminist argument — the assertion of a woman's right to choose her own life against family and social compulsion — with sympathy and precision, noting both its theatrical strengths and the particular difficulty of staging feminist critique within a Maithili theatrical tradition that has historically been more comfortable with social comedy than with social protest. The review of the Maithili Chitrakatha (comic books, essay 8) shows his attentiveness to new and hybrid forms, recognising that the expansion of Maithili into visual storytelling is not a dilution of the literary tradition but an extension of its reach.

The essay 'Maithilik Vikasme Baal Kavitaak Yogdan' (essay 18 — 'The Contribution of Children's Poetry to the Development of Maithili') is notable for its programmatic urgency. Tillu argues that children's poetry in Maithili has been seriously underdeveloped, and that the literary establishment's tendency to classify religious verses and educational rhymes as 'children's literature' misses the specific psychological and aesthetic requirements of the child reader. He

calls for poetry rooted in the Maithili names for things — the gachhi (mango orchard), the bhutaka-nath (scarecrow), the village games — as the only foundation on which a genuine Maithili children's literature can be built. This is not sentimental nostalgia but a programmatic claim about language survival: if children do not find their world reflected in Maithili literature, they will not read Maithili literature.

# IV. Shiv Kumar Jha 'Tillu' in the Videha Parallel History Framework

## IV.1 The Parallel Tradition and Its Writers

The Videha Parallel History of Mithila and Maithili Literature, authored by Gajendra Thakur and serialised on www.videha.co.in, establishes a counter-canonical account of Maithili letters that challenges the Sahitya Akademi's version at every level — chronological, social, formal, and epistemological. Its central argument is that the mainstream Maithili canon has been produced by and for the upper-caste (primarily Maithil Brahmin) elite, systematically excluding democratic, subaltern, feminist, and Nepal-side traditions. Its alternative canon includes the Buddhist Charyapadas as the genuine origin of Maithili lyric, the suppressed Harimohan Jha as the most significant modern novelist, Rajdeo Mandal as the greatest living poet, Bechan Thakur as the greatest living dramatist, and Jagdish Prasad Mandal as the greatest novelist of the last century.

Tillu sits in a specific position within this framework: he is a Maithil Brahmin by birth who writes both poetry and criticism from a position of internal critique — questioning the canonical preferences of his own community's literary establishment, praising the parallel tradition's writers with genuine critical engagement, and producing creative work that embodies the parallel tradition's values (formal range, social consciousness, ecological awareness, cultural urgency) without making propagandistic claims.

His Videha connection — beginning with the online feedback column and developing through the publication of both his books under Shruti Prakashan (Videha's affiliated press) — locates him institutionally within the parallel movement, even as his caste position gives his critique of the mainstream a

particular kind of authority: the authority of the insider who refuses the insider's privileges.

## IV.2 The Gaṅgeśa Connection: Navya Nyāya and Critical Practice

The Videha Parallel History's recovery of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's intercaste origins — his mother said to be a Charmkāriṇī (leather-tanning caste woman), his birth five years after his father's death, according to original Dooshan Panji records — is not merely a biographical curiosity. It reframes the entire tradition of Navya Nyāya as something that emerged from the social margins of Mithila's caste system rather than from its brahminical centre. The philosopher who created the most rigorous epistemological system in pre-modern India — the Tattvacintāmaṇi with its doctrine of valid knowledge, its four pramāṇas, its technical analysis of inference and testimony — was himself, according to original genealogical records, a product of intercaste social reality.

This reframing has direct implications for how we read Tillu's critical practice in Aṃśu. When Tillu tests the Sahitya Akademi's anthology against the evidence of Maithili literary history and finds it wanting — when he establishes, through the patient assembly of counter-evidence, that the anthology's claim to represent 'contemporary Maithili poetry' is false — he is performing an operation that is structurally analogous to the Navya Nyāya procedure of ābhāsa-analysis: the identification of epistemic errors (jñānābhāsa) in a claim that presents itself as valid knowledge.

The four pramāṇas of Navya Nyāya — pratyakṣa (perception), anumāna (inference), upamāna (analogy/comparison), and śabda (testimony) — map onto Tillu's critical practice as follows. Pratyakṣa: his direct reading of the texts under review, attending to language, structure, and image. Anumāna: his inference from patterns of inclusion and exclusion to the underlying social logic of canonical construction. Upamāna: his comparative placing of Maithili texts in relation to each other and to texts from other traditions (Hindi, Bengali, Sanskrit). Śabda: his use of existing critical testimony — including the statements of the authors themselves, the assessments of earlier critics, and the documentary evidence of Videha's RTI investigation — as sources of knowledge that must be evaluated for their reliability (āpta vs anāpta, reliable vs unreliable testimony).

When Tillu writes, in the Aṃśu preface, that 'criticism should not be criticism but samālocanā — examining from all ten directions' — he is invoking, perhaps without knowing it, the Navya Nyāya ideal of comprehensive epistemic investigation: the pramātā (knowing subject) who does not settle for a single perspective but multiplies the means of valid knowledge (pramāṇas) until the prameya (object of knowledge) is fully illuminated. This is not a coincidence of method but a convergence of intellectual traditions that both have their roots in the same Mithila soil.

## IV.3 The Institutional Politics of Recognition

Within the Parallel History Framework, the question of institutional recognition — who receives Sahitya Akademi awards, whose books are translated, whose work is included in anthologies — is not a peripheral concern but a central one. The RTI investigation by Vinit Utpal and Ashish Anchinhar (2011-14) established that over 90 per cent of Sahitya Akademi translation and publication assignments went to friends, relatives, and associates of the ten-member Maithili advisory board — a pattern of distribution that the Parallel History characterises as systemic epistemic violence against the writers of the parallel tradition.

Tillu's name does not appear on the list of recognised Sahitya Akademi writers — despite publishing two substantial and important contributions to Maithili letters by 2013. This is not surprising within the framework of the Parallel History: his institutional base (Shruti Prakashan, Videha, the Pallavi distribution network), his critical positions (explicitly challenging the anthology edited by Bhimnath Jha, a figure of the mainstream), and his thematic commitments (Dalit representation, women's writing, environmental critique) all mark him as a writer of the parallel tradition who will not find favour with the advisory board's patronage networks.

From the Navya Nyāya perspective, the non-recognition of Tillu's work by the Sahitya Akademi is an instance of āpta-parīkṣā (the examination of testimony's reliability) gone wrong: the advisory board, which is the institutional source of testimony about Maithili literary value, is demonstrably unreliable (anāpta) because it is corrupted by social and familial interests that are inconsistent with the disinterested pursuit of literary quality.

# V. Western Critical Frameworks Applied

## V.1 New Criticism and Formal Analysis

The New Critical approach — associated with Cleanth Brooks, Robert Penn Warren, and John Crowe Ransom — emphasises close reading of the poem as a verbal artefact, attending to tension, irony, paradox, and the organic unity of form and content. Applied to Tillu's poetry, this approach reveals the technical sophistication of his apparently simple verse. The viraha poems achieve their effects through the precise calibration of natural imagery against emotional state — the koel's call, the bee's drone, the spring blossoms as amplifiers of longing rather than consolations. Brooks's concept of 'the paradox at the heart of poetry' applies directly to the haiku about Maithili language: the language's voicelessness is enacted in the haiku's radical economy — saying little, meaning much, in a form that itself embodies the compression of linguistic survival.

The New Critical principle of 'organic form' — the idea that a poem's form is not an external container but an expression of its content — is demonstrated across Kṣaṇaprabhā's formal range. The festive Holi poems use the gīt's refrain-based structure because the Holi tradition is itself refrain-based, communal, participatory. The ghazals use their discipline of the repeated radif to enact the inescapability of the social condition they describe. The haiku use compression to enact linguistic precarity. Each formal choice is an argument.

## V.2 Reader-Response Theory

Wolfgang Iser's model of the literary work as a structured set of gaps that the reader fills through an act of creative completion is particularly relevant to Tillu's critical essays in Aṃśu. The essays are written with the assumption of a Maithili reader who needs no introduction to the works under review — the references to Harimohan Jha's Kanyadaan, to Yatri's Paro, to Rajkamal's avant-garde position, to Jagdish Prasad Mandal's social vision are all made with the confidence of a critic addressing an audience within the tradition. For non-Maithili readers, these gaps become sites of productive learning: the essays function as cultural orientation as much as critical assessment.

Stanley Fish's concept of the 'interpretive community' — the idea that meaning is produced not by individual readers but by communities of readers who share conventions of interpretation — applies to Tillu's position as a critic formed

within the Videha community. His interpretive conventions — the primacy of social embeddedness, the value of linguistic authenticity, the importance of Dalit and women's representation — are not universal but specific to the interpretive community of the parallel Maithili movement. Reading Aṃśu from outside this community requires a conscious act of cultural translation.

## V.3 Postcolonial and Subaltern Theory

Edward Said's concept of 'contrapuntal reading' — reading the silences and gaps of a dominant text against the grain to recover the experiences it suppresses — is Tillu's method in his critique of the Sahitya Akademi anthology. He reads the anthology's silences (the absent women poets, the absent dalit voices, the absent political dissidents) as counterpoints to its explicit claims, producing a reading that is not supplementary to the text but critical of its own conditions of production.

Homi Bhabha's notion of 'hybridity' illuminates Tillu's formal practice in Kṣaṇaprabhā: the adaptation of haiku into Maithili, the deployment of ghazal form with Maithili content, the mixing of classical viraha conventions with contemporary social critique — these are all productions of the 'third space' that Bhabha identifies as the site of new cultural meaning. Tillu is not a purist of either the classical or the modern; his work inhabits the productive tension between them.

Ranajit Guha's concept of 'the prose of counter-insurgency' — the way official discourse misrepresents subaltern agency by reframing subaltern action as disorder and pathology — has its literary-critical equivalent in what Tillu identifies in Aṃśu: the 'prose of canonical construction,' the way official Maithili literary historiography misrepresents the parallel tradition as secondary, derivative, or non-existent. His critical work is a form of counter-narration — not in the sense of mere opposition but in the Guha sense of restoring the complexity and agency that the canonical account suppresses.

## V.4 New Historicism and Cultural Materialism

Stephen Greenblatt's New Historicism insists on reading literary texts as embedded in and shaped by the 'social energy' of their historical moment — not as transcendent aesthetic objects but as nodes in the networks of power, exchange, and negotiation that constitute social life. Applied to Kṣaṇaprabhā,

this approach reveals the collection as a culturally specific document of the Maithili-speaking world in the first decade of the twenty-first century: the outmigration crisis, the ecological pressure of chemical agriculture and flood-management failures, the tension between Hindi-belt cultural standardisation and Maithili linguistic particularity, the shifting demographics of caste in the north Bihar countryside.

Raymond Williams's concept of the 'structure of feeling' — the lived, pre-theoretical, affective engagement with social conditions that precedes formal ideological articulation — is what Kṣaṇaprabhā offers at its best: not a programme or a manifesto but a sensibility, a way of being in the Maithili world that attends to its textures and pressures with lyric precision.

## VI. Synthesis: Strengths, Limitations, and Significance

### VI.1 Strengths

Tillu's achievement across Kṣaṇaprabhā and Aṃśu is distinctive for its combination of formal range, social commitment, and critical rigour. As a poet, his primary strengths are formal flexibility (his comfort across the gīt, lyric, haiku, ghazal, and satirical verse traditions), the authenticity of his relationship to the Maithili cultural landscape (the seasonal poems and festive verse are culturally embedded in ways that resist the universalising gestures of much contemporary Indian poetry), and the courage of his social critique (the dalit poems, the environmental satire, the feminist sympathy of the Vibha Rani review). As a critic, his primary strengths are the systematic quality of his survey methods, the directness of his assessment (he names failures as well as achievements), and the ethical seriousness of his engagement with questions of representation and exclusion.

Within the Videha Parallel History Framework, Tillu represents a type of writer who is structurally underrepresented: the upper-caste-by-birth writer who uses his literary formation to critique the exclusions of his own tradition. This is not a comfortable position — it involves the risk of being rejected by both the mainstream (which objects to his critical positions) and the parallel tradition (which may suspect his motives). That he navigates this position with integrity is itself a significant achievement.

## VI.2 Areas for Development

A balanced critical appreciation must also note the areas where Tillu's work invites further development. The poetry collection Kṣaṇaprabhā, for all its formal range and cultural richness, is occasionally uneven in its execution: some of the longer social-satirical poems lose their lyric density in the pursuit of comprehensiveness, and a more disciplined formal editing might have produced a tighter, more consistently strong collection. The critical essays in Aṃśu are more variable in their depth: the opening essay on Dalit representation and the second essay on the Sahitya Akademi anthology are sustained and rigorous; some of the shorter reviews are more appreciative than analytical, stopping short of the close formal engagement that would make them fully satisfying as criticism.

A future project that brings Tillu's dual capacities — his poetic sensibility and his critical intelligence — into a more explicit dialogue would be a significant contribution. A sustained poetics, or a more ambitious series of full-length critical monographs on individual Maithili writers, would extend the work of Aṃśu into the territory of systematic literary historiography that the parallel tradition still needs.

## VI.3 The Question of Legacy

Shiv Kumar Jha 'Tillu' is at the time of writing a mid-career writer whose most significant contributions may yet lie ahead. What is already clear from Kṣaṇaprabhā and Aṃśu is that he represents a serious and committed literary intelligence working within the Maithili parallel tradition — one who takes the responsibilities of both poet and critic seriously, who honours the tradition's past while engaging with its present, and who refuses the temptations of either institutional accommodation or populist gesture.

The Navya Nyāya tradition's insistence on the primacy of pramā — valid, verifiable, honestly arrived-at knowledge — as against the comfortable repetition of received opinion (svīkṛti without examination) is the deep methodological principle that Tillu's work embodies. Whether examining a Sahitya Akademi anthology or writing a poem about the monsoon's failure, he is doing the same thing: attending honestly to the evidence, resisting the easy

conclusion, and insisting that language — whether in poetry or criticism — must earn its truth.

## VII. Conclusion: The Flash and What It Illuminates

'Kṣaṇaprabhā' — the momentary flash of lightning — is a humble title for a writer who disclaims the mantle of 'natural poet.' But the flash of lightning, in the Maithili and Sanskrit traditions, is not merely humble: it is the sudden illumination of what is always present but invisible in the dark. Tillu's poetry and criticism perform exactly this function. They do not create new social realities or invent new literary possibilities; they illuminate what is already there — the richness of the Maithili lyric tradition, the depth of Dalit experience in Mithila's fiction, the structural injustice of the canonical exclusions, the ecological grief of a landscape under pressure.

Viewed through the multiple analytical lenses assembled in this appreciation — the rasa theory of Bharata, the dhvani theory of Ānandavardhana, the aucitya principle of Kṣemendra, the Navya Nyāya epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya, the Videha Parallel History Framework of Gajendra Thakur, and the Western critical traditions from New Criticism to postcolonial theory — Shiv Kumar Jha 'Tillu' emerges as a figure whose significance exceeds the modest scale of his published output. He is a link in the chain of transmission that keeps the parallel Maithili tradition alive and growing — a poet who carries the formal inheritance of the gīt and the viraha lyric into new social territory, and a critic who uses the tools of close reading and systematic analysis to make the invisible visible.

The 'Kṣaṇaprabhā' — the momentary flash — does not illuminate everything. But what it illuminates, it illuminates with clarity. That is not a small achievement. It is the beginning of the work that the Maithili literary tradition, in its fullest and most democratic form, still needs to do. To date, Tillu ji has written more than 8,000 verses, including both poems and songs.

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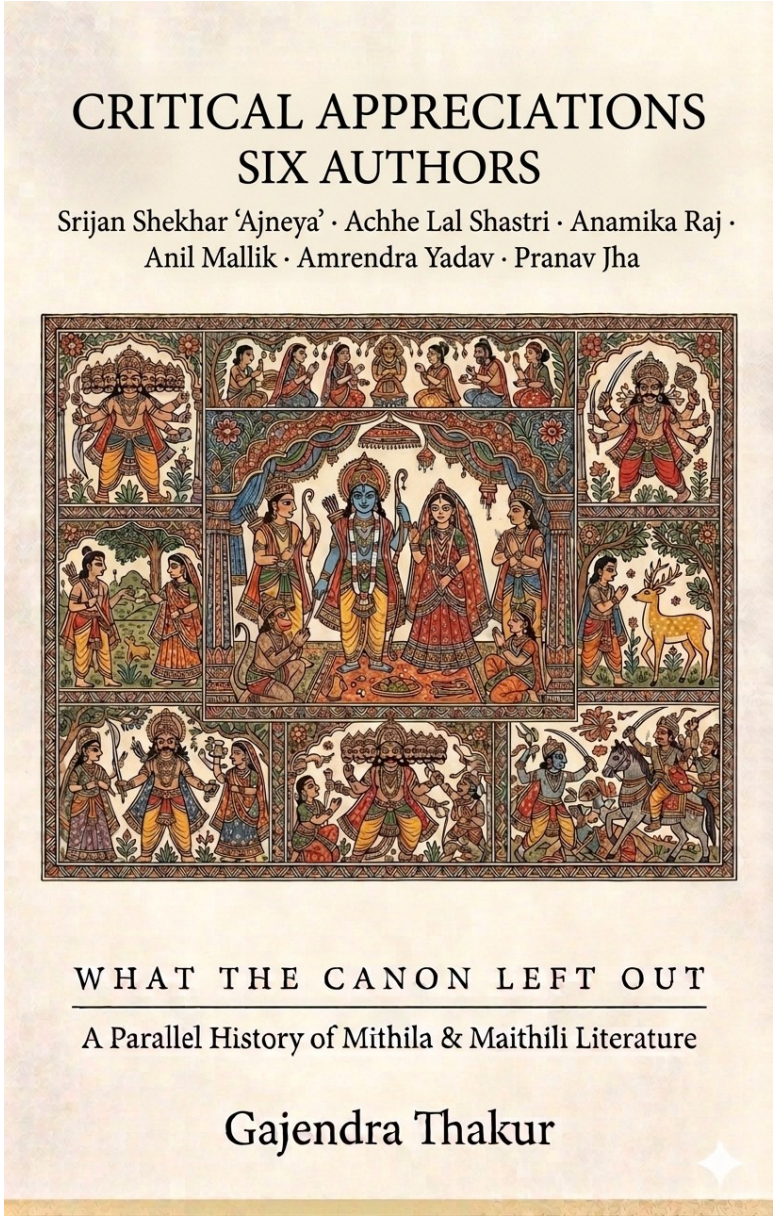
*Maithili passages have been rendered in approximate English paraphrase for the purposes of critical analysis; full translations would require a separate scholarly undertaking.*

**LESSON 084 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**



# CRITICAL APPRECIATIONS

*Srijan Shekhar 'Ajneya' · Achhe Lal Shastri · Anamika Raj · Anil Mallik · Amrendra Yadav · Pranav Jha*

*Indian & Western Literary Theory · Videha Parallel History Framework · Navya-Nyāya of Gaṅgeśa*

**SRIJAN SHEKHAR 'AJNEYA' (GANGANAND JHA)**

सृजन शेखर 'अज्ञेय' (मूल नाम: गंगानन्द झा)

*Committed Song-Writer · Social Gīta Composer · Pseudonymous Identity*

## Archive Presence & Works

Sadeha 18: Gīta Sāṃ Pahine + Hāṁ + Jīnagī Ke Dastāveza + Saba Maithila Ke Lela + Preme Ke Gīta-Sṛjana + Hamara Gāma + Jīnagī Ke Gīta + Gīta Ego Sapanā (pp. 1228–1245) | Sadeha 19: Dūṭā Kavitā (pp. 1000–1003) | Sadeha 21: Kakarā Abite Jādū Bhaँ Jāya Re (p. 1129)

Srijan Shekhar 'Ajneya' — whose real name is Ganganand Jha (गंगानन्द झा) — adopts a pen-name of remarkable literary-historical resonance: Ajneya (अज्ञेय) is the pen-name of Sachchidananda Hirananda Vatsyayan, one of the greatest Hindi modernist poets of the 20th century, founder of the Tār Saptak anthology tradition and a major figure of the Prayogvāda (Experimentalist) movement. The choice of 'Ajneya' as a Maithili pen-name is a conscious claim to the modernist literary tradition while the 'Srijan Shekhar' (Creator's Summit/Crest) compounds the literary ambition. His Sadeha 18 contribution is his most substantial: eight song-poems whose titles encapsulate his dominant themes — Gīta Sāṃ Pahine (Before the Song, suggesting the pre-literary moment of creative conception), Hāṁ (We/I — the first-person plural assertion), Jīnagī Ke Dastāveza (Documents of Life), and the personal Hamara Gāma (Our Village). Sadeha 21's Kakarā Abite Jādū Bhaँ Jāya Re (When Whom Comes, Magic Happens — literally 'To Whose Coming Does Magic Happen?') is a lyric of expectation and transformation.

## Thematic & Critical Analysis

The pen-name Ajneya carries the weight of the entire Hindi modernist project: Vatsyayan's Ajneya was committed to individual consciousness, experimental form, and the rejection of ideological prescription in literature. Ganganand Jha's adoption of this name for Maithili suggests an aspiration to bring the modernist commitment to individual consciousness and formal experimentation into the Maithili literary tradition. Jīnagī Ke Dastāveza (Documents of Life) as a title invokes the documentary-literary tradition — the poem as evidence, the song as historical record. Saba Maithila Ke Lela (For All Maithili People) is the democratic address that characterises the Videha Parallel History's community orientation. The movement from Gīta Sāṃ Pahine (before the song — the creative origin) through the song-sequence to Gīta Ego Sapanā (The Song Is a Dream) traces a creative-philosophical arc from pre-expression through engagement to the dream-status of the literary work.

## Theoretical Frameworks

Vatsyayan-Ajneya's modernism as intertextual frame: the pen-name establishes a dialogue between Hindi modernism and Maithili literary aspiration. Dhvani (Ānandavardhana): 'Kakarā Abite Jādū Bha̍ Jāya Re' generates resonant dhvani — the unnamed 'whom' (kakara) can be the beloved, the spring season, the political liberator, or the divine. Navya-Nyāya: 'Jīnagī Ke Dastāveza' — life as the object of a documentary anumāna: from specific life-events (hetu) through the general principle of human experience (vyāpti) to the universal conclusion (sādhya). The Videha Parallel History: the pseudonymous identity question — the real name (Ganganand Jha) vs the literary name (Srijan Shekhar Ajneya) — enacts the tension between biographical and literary identity that the Framework navigates throughout its archive.

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**ACHHE LAL SHASTRI**

अच्छेलाल शास्त्री

*Witness Poet · Shravana 2010 Flood Poet · Raṇabhūmi Critical Voice*

## Archive Presence & Works

Sadeha 7 (Prelim_7): Kī Dekha Rahala Chī? + Dū Hajāra Dasa Śrāvaṇaka Dṛśya | Sadeha 10 (Prelim_10): Raṇabhūmi Ā Kavitā | Sadeha 30 (Prelim_30): Raṇabhūmi Ā Kavitā — Dū Śabda (p. 1964, critical note)

Achhe Lal Shastri (अच्छेलाल शास्त्री) is a poet whose name carries immediate social significance: 'Achhe Lal' is a common OBC/lower-caste given name in Bihar (literally 'Good Red'), combined with the high-caste Sanskrit title 'Shastri' (one learned in the śāstras/sacred texts) — a combination that either indicates genuine Sanskrit learning in an OBC household, or a social mobility claim through naming. The title Shastri as a pen-name or earned title in an OBC context is itself a democratising statement. His Sadeha 7 poems reveal a poet of immediate social witness: 'Kī Dekha Rahala Chī?' (What Are You Looking At?/What Am I Looking At?) is a direct-address question of witness and complicity; 'Dū Hajāra Dasa Śrāvaṇaka Dṛśya' (A Scene from the Shravana Month of 2010) is a documentary poem specifically dated to the July-August 2010 flood season in Bihar — one of the most devastating recent flood years in Mithilanchal, when the Koshi and other rivers caused catastrophic damage. His 'Raṇabhūmi Ā Kavitā' (Battlefield and Poetry) — appearing in both Sadeha 10 and as a critical discussion in Sadeha 30 — is both a poem and a topic of critical debate.

## Thematic & Critical Analysis

The title 'Kī Dekha Rahala Chī?' is among the most Brechtian in the entire Videha archive: it directly interrogates the position of the witness, the act of seeing, and the question of what one does with what one sees. 'Dū Hajāra Dasa Śrāvaṇaka Dṛśya' is flood documentary poetry: the poem as a scene (dṛśya), precisely dated, from a specific moment of natural-social catastrophe. The poem-as-scene is a distinctively visual mode — it asks the reader to see what

the poem sees. 'Raṇabhūmi Ā Kavitā' (Battlefield and Poetry) raises the fundamental question of the relationship between violent social conflict and literary production: what is the poet's responsibility in a landscape that has become a battlefield?

## Theoretical Frameworks

Brecht's Verfremdungseffekt and witness: 'Kī Dekha Rahala Chī?' is a defamiliarising question that makes the act of seeing strange and demands self-reflection from the reader. Documentary poetics (Charles Bernstein's 'Artifice of Absorption' and the documentary poetry tradition): the dated flood poem as evidence-poetry, the poem as historical document. Navya-Nyāya pratyakṣa: the flood witness's direct perception of the Shravana 2010 catastrophe as the highest form of poetic knowledge — what was seen cannot be unseen. The Videha Parallel History: Shastri's OBC voice, his flood documentation, and his reflection on poetry's relationship to conflict all align with the Framework's commitment to democratic witness.

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**ANAMIKA RAJ**

अनामिका राज

*Feminist Poet · Path-Seeker · Subaltern Woman Voice*

## Archive Presence & Works

Sadeha 7 (Prelim_7): Navakā Bāṭa (New Path) | Sadeha 15 (Prelim_15): Sīmā (p. 32) + Kṣamatāvāna (pp. 283–284)

Anamika Raj (अनामिका राज) writes under a pen-name whose components are both significant: Anamika (अनामिका) means 'nameless' or 'ring-finger' — a name that encodes anonymity and the feminine (the ring-finger is associated with marriage and feminine identity in Indian tradition). Raj (राज) means 'kingdom' or 'rule' — the nameless woman who rules, or the woman who rules through her namelessness, claiming power precisely through the identity that patriarchy has denied her. Her Sadeha 7 piece Navakā Bāṭa (New Path) announces the thematic of path-finding and self-creation that characterises the feminist literary imagination. Her Sadeha 15 contributions — Sīmā (Boundary/Limit) and Kṣamatāvāna (The Powerful/The Capable One) — extend this thematic: 'Sīmā' explores the limits placed on women's lives; 'Kṣamatāvāna' asserts women's capacity and power in defiance of those limits.

## Thematic & Critical Analysis

The three pieces together constitute a feminist arc: Navakā Bāṭa (new path — the foundational move of feminist self-creation), Sīmā (the boundary that must be crossed or transformed), and Kṣamatāvāna (the powerful one who can cross or transform the boundary). This is the structure of feminist narrative that Rich identifies: the discovery of the lesbian continuum/woman-identified experience (Shanti Lakshmi's contribution to the same archive) finds its complementary statement in Anamika Raj's path-seeking and power-assertion. Her pen-name's encoding of the 'nameless' woman who claims power through her naming makes her one of the most self-consciously feminist literary identities in the Videha archive.

## Theoretical Frameworks

Rich's 'Compulsory Heterosexuality and Lesbian Existence': Anamika Raj's Sīmā (boundary) and Navakā Bāṭa (new path) are the formal statement of what Rich analyses as the central problem of women's existence — the boundaries that constrain, and the paths that resist those constraints. Navya-Nyāya: 'Kṣamatāvāna' as an epistemological claim — the assertion that the woman (or subaltern) is kṣamatāvāna (capable of knowing, acting, transforming) is a claim about the conditions of valid pramāṇa that extend to previously excluded knowers. The Videha Parallel History: Anamika Raj's feminist voice, alongside

Shanti Lakshmi Chaudhary's and Munni Kamat's, constitutes the women's strand of the Parallel History's democratic archive.

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**ANIL MALLIK**

अनिल मल्लिक

*Most Prolific Early Videha Ghazal Poet · Grandmother's Song Tradition · Voice of Commitment*

## Archive Presence & Works

Sadeha 7: Gīta + Āzād Ghazal 1–3 + Hama Kahi Daita Chī + Svīkārokti | Sadeha 9: Dādīka Gīta | Sadeha 10: Hama, Deha Ā Videha...! | Sadeha 11: Ghazal | Sadeha 12: Ghazal 1–2 | Sadeha 13: Ghazal 1–2 | Sadeha 14: Ghazal (p. 596) | Sadeha 15: Ghazal (p. 270)

Anil Mallik (अनिल मल्लिक) has the most sustained continuous presence among all ghazal poets in the Videha archive's early phase, with confirmed contributions across eight Sadeha volumes (7, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15) — making him arguably the most consistently documented ghazal poet in the first fifteen Sadeha volumes. His Sadeha 7 contribution establishes his range immediately: Gīta (song), Āzād Ghazal 1–3 (three free ghazals), Hama Kahi Daita Chī (I Will/Do Say It — an assertion of voice), and Svīkārokti (Confession/Acknowledgement — a philosophically loaded title suggesting the speaker's self-critical admission). His surname Mallik (from the Arabic malik, meaning king/master) is found across communities in Bihar — both Muslim and Hindu — suggesting a diverse communal positioning. Dādīka Gīta (Grandmother's Song) in Sadeha 9 is his most culturally specific contribution: a song in the tradition of the grandmother's oral transmission of folk culture —

the role that Maithili's women's oral tradition plays in preserving and transmitting the cultural heritage across generations.

## Thematic & Critical Analysis

Anil Mallik's sustained presence across eight Sadeha volumes, combined with Hama Deha Ā Videha (I, Body and Non-Body/Videha) in Sadeha 10 — whose title is a philosophical-literary triple pun (Videha = the Maithili kingdom, videha = bodiless/spiritual, and the journal Videha itself), marks him as one of the most self-aware participants in the Videha project. Hama Kahi Daita Chī (I Will Say It/I Do Say It) is an assertion of speech-act — the poem itself enacts what it names: the speaking. Svīkārokti (Confession) suggests the tradition of the speaker acknowledging their own limitations or errors — a form of lyric humility that is rare in the Maithili ghazal tradition's characteristic assertiveness. Dādīka Gīta connects his work to the women's oral cultural transmission tradition that the Parallel History prizes: the grandmother's song is the repository of the most ancient Maithili folk knowledge.

## Theoretical Frameworks

Rasa: Anil Mallik's corpus spans the full rasa range — from the Hāsya of possible satirical pieces to the Śṛṅgāra of love ghazals to the Karuṇa of social observation to the Vīra of Hama Kahi Daita Chī. Navya-Nyāya: 'Hama Deha Ā Videha' — the philosophical distinction between the embodied (deha) and the disembodied (videha) self maps onto Gaṅgeśa's distinction between the ātman as the locus of consciousness and the body as the material substrate of experience. The grandmother's song as śabda-pramāṇa of the deepest kind: the oral transmission across generations carries the accumulated knowledge of the community's experience. The Videha Parallel History: Mallik's eight-volume presence makes him the archive's most consistent early ghazal voice.

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**AMRENDRA YADAV**

अमरेन्द्र यादव

*OBC-Yadav Short Fiction Writer · Satirical Voice · Report-Form Innovator*

## Archive Presence & Works

Sadeha 33 (Prelim_33): Ṭamaṭamiyāṃ Ghoḍā (p. 626) | Sadeha 34 (Prelim_34): Ripōrṭa (pp. 417–420)

Amrendra Yadav is a Maithili fiction writer in the short-form tradition, with two confirmed Videha contributions in Sadeha 33 and 34. His Sadeha 33 piece 'Ṭamaṭamiyāṃ Ghoḍā' (Tottering/Wobbly Horse) is a title of satirical-comic resonance: the tamaṭamiyāṃ ghoḍā (the horse that totters or wobbles) is both a literal image of an unsteady animal and a metaphor for any unstable system, person, or institution that presents itself as capable of moving forward while visibly failing to do so. His Sadeha 34 piece 'Ripōrṭa' (Report) — a Maithili short fiction piece with an English/Hindi-origin title — is formally innovative in using the bureaucratic-journalistic genre ('report') as a literary frame for fiction, creating a documentary-fictional hybrid.

## Thematic & Critical Analysis

The 'tottering horse' image is a classic folk metaphor in rural Bihar-Mithila: the horse (ghoḍā) is an animal of status and aspiration in the village economy, but a tottering horse is a figure of failed aspiration — the status-symbol that cannot support its own weight. This connects to the Bihar political tradition where symbols of power (horses, elephants in political processions) are subject to satirical commentary. 'Ripōrṭa' as a literary title creates a fruitful ambiguity: a 'report' in bureaucratic terms is an objective, fact-based document; a literary 'report' is a subjective narrative that mimics the bureaucratic form. The gap between the claimed objectivity of the report-genre and the lived subjectivity of the literary story is the source of the piece's likely irony.

## Theoretical Frameworks

Bakhtin's parody (Problems of Dostoevsky's Poetics): 'Ripōrṭa' is parody in the technical Bakhtinian sense — it takes a non-literary genre (the bureaucratic report) and places it in a literary context where it is both itself and its own ironic commentary. The tottering horse as vakrokti (Kuntaka): the oblique expression of political/social instability through the unexpected image of a failing animal. Navya-Nyāya: the 'report' as a form of śabda-pramāṇa — and the literary parody of the report as an exposure of the conditions under which official testimony is not, in fact, reliable pramāṇa. The Videha Parallel History: Yadav's OBC-Yadav identity and his satirical-documentary mode contribute to the archive's diversity of community voice and genre.

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**PRANAV JHA (PRANAV KUMAR JHA)**

प्रणव झा / प्रणव कुमार झा

*Most Prolific Multi-Genre Writer · Dramatist · Memoirist · Fiction Writer · Medical Essayist · Social Critic*

## Archive Presence & Works

Sadeha 17: Ambara + Tesara Praṇa + Apana Apana Dharma (Saṃsmaraṇa) (pp. 705–715) | Sadeha 19: Lagu Kathā — Nava-Āśā (pp. 309–313) + Alara-Balara (pp. 1342–1346) | Sadeha 20: Sadācāra Ka Tāvīja (Nāṭikā) + Rājā Khānadāna (Saṃsmaraṇa) + Facebook Kē Cakkara + Cakraphāṃsa + Arajala Jamīna + Rakṣitā + Sukhāita Pokhaira Pyāsala Gāma (pp. 546–603) | Sadeha 21: Dosara Biyāha + Canmā + Maithilī Kathāme Strī + Ekaṭā Janmejaya Kathā (pp. 13–35)

| Sadeha 22: Lagu Kathā: Giddha + N.P.S. (pp. 43–50) | Sadeha 23: Kī Chai 'DNB' (Medical essay) (pp. from contents)

Pranav Jha (also written as Pranav Kumar Jha) is the most multi-genre writer in the group under consideration, with documented contributions across six Sadeha volumes (17, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23) spanning drama, memoir/saṃsmaraṇa, short fiction (lagu kathā), social satire, Facebook-era commentary, legal-social fiction, medical journalism, and literary criticism ('Maithilī Kathāme Strī' — Women in Maithili Fiction). His single largest contribution is Sadeha 20's 58-page section (pp. 546–603) which includes a nāṭikā (one-act play), a memoir, Facebook commentary, the piece Cakraphāṃsa (Spiral Trap/Vicious Circle), Arajala Jamīna (Contested/Unmapped Land), Rakṣitā (The Protected One/Mistress — a socially provocative title), and Sukhāita Pokhaira Pyāsala Gāma (The Dried-Up Pond, Thirsty Village). The essay 'Maithilī Kathāme Strī' in Sadeha 21 makes him one of the few male writers in the archive who explicitly theorises women's representation in Maithili fiction.

## Thematic & Critical Analysis

Pranav Jha's corpus is the Videha Parallel History's most comprehensive single-author documentation of contemporary Maithili society's digital transition: Facebook Kē Cakkara (The Facebook Whirl), Ānalāīna pieces in the same volume, and the engagement with social media all position him as the archive's primary chronicler of the digital social moment. Rakṣitā (The Protected One/Kept Woman) is the most socially provocative title in his corpus — addressing the category of the rakṣitā (a woman kept in a protected but socially ambiguous relationship) raises questions of female agency, social vulnerability, and moral judgment that a male writer must navigate carefully. Cakraphāṃsa (Vicious Circle/Spiral Trap) is a systems-analysis title applied to social reality — the way poverty, education deprivation, and social discrimination form self-reinforcing cycles. 'Maithilī Kathāme Strī' as a critical essay subject places him in the tradition of male feminist criticism — the examination by a male writer of how women are represented in male-authored Maithili fiction. 'Kī Chai DNB' (What Is DNB) is medical journalism — documenting the DNB (Diplomate of National Board) qualification programme for district hospitals — placing him in the tradition of health-rights journalism.

## Theoretical Frameworks

Habermas: Pranav Jha's multi-form corpus spans all three of Habermas's rationality domains — instrumental (medical essay, legal-social fiction), communicative (saṃsmaraṇa, drama, fiction), and critical (feminist literary criticism, social satire). The Facebook pieces are an analysis of the new public sphere that social media creates. Navya-Nyāya: 'Cakraphāṃsa' (Vicious Circle) is a formal anumāna structure — the vyāpti of self-reinforcing systemic disadvantage leading to the sādhya of structural critique. Spivak: the essay 'Maithilī Kathāme Strī' is a male intellectual's critical engagement with women's representation — an engagement that is both necessary and problematic, requiring the critical tools that Spivak's question 'Can the Subaltern Speak?' demands. The Videha Parallel History: Pranav Jha's multi-genre, multi-Sadeha presence makes him one of the most comprehensive documenters of the democratic Maithili literary community's social reality.

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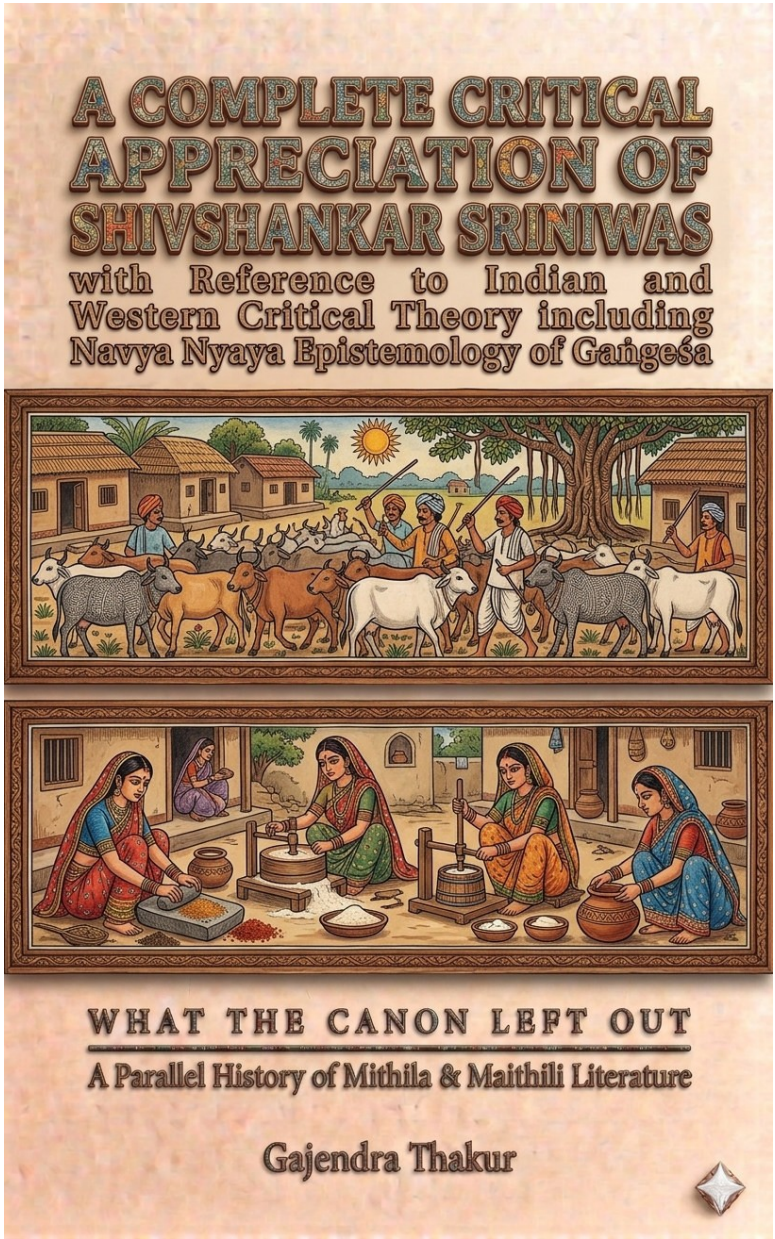
**LESSON 085 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**



# A COMPLETE CRITICAL APPRECIATION OF

# SHIVSHANKAR SRINIWAS

*(Sri Shivshankar Srinivas, b. 02 July 1953)*

with Reference to Indian and Western Critical Theory

*including Navya Nyaya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa*

With Comparative Analysis of Kathakar Ashok and Kumar Pawan

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## I. PREFACE AND SCOPE OF THE STUDY

Shivshankar Sriniwas (literary name; original name Shivshankar Jha) stands as one of the most significant and yet insufficiently appreciated voices in contemporary Maithili literature. Born on 2 July 1953 in Lohana village, Madhubani district, Bihar, he has, over five decades, produced a body of fiction that illuminates the rural lifescape of Mithila with unusual sociological precision, linguistic authenticity, and quiet moral seriousness. The special commemorative issue of Videha (Issue 424, August 2025), which is dedicated entirely to him, marks a landmark moment in the critical recognition of his oeuvre.

This critical appreciation draws on: (1) the primary texts available in the enclosed archive — including his story collection Chayanit Katha, Mati, and critical writings — (2) the Videha 424 special issue, which gathers nineteen critical essays, editorial commentary, and reader responses, (3) The Wire interview (May 2025), (4) published scholarship in IJCRT and other journals, and (5) contextual knowledge of Maithili literary history. The study applies both Western critical frameworks — including New Criticism, narratology, postcolonial theory, and feminist criticism — and Indian theoretical traditions, foremost among them Rasa-dhvani aesthetics and, centrally, the Navya Nyaya epistemological methodology of Gangesa Upadhyaya (c. 1325 CE), whose

intellectual tradition is organically tied to the Mithila region where Sriniwas himself was born and works.

A comparative dimension is also provided, situating Sriniwas alongside his contemporaries and co-generational peers: Kathakar Ashok (Ashok Kumar Jha, b. 18 January 1953) and Kumar Pawan, whose contrasting aesthetic choices and thematic preoccupations provide a useful illuminating counterpoint.

## II. BIOGRAPHICAL OVERVIEW

Shivshankar Sriniwas — whose actual birth date is 13 September 1953 but whose certificate records 2 July 1953 — was born in Lohana, Madhubani, Bihar, to Smt. Jaya Devi and late Sri Badrinath Jha. He received his foundational oral literary education from his paternal grandmother, Smt. Ram Pyari Devi, to whom he attributes his earliest story-listening and story-telling instincts. He completed his M.A. and Ph.D. and went on to serve as a lecturer in Maithili. He is married to Vasundhara Devi, who publishes under the pen name Meena Madhu. Together they have four children.

His literary awakening is traced to a 1965 poetry gathering at Sarisab Lakshmi Eshwar Academy when he was in the eighth grade. Poetry gave way to prose by the 1970s, and his earliest stories were published and received with enthusiasm even as some dismissed them. What sustained him was the encouragement of his friend and peer Kathakar Ashok, as well as the patronage of the renowned fiction writer Dhirendra and the poet Harekrishna Jha. He has described writing as a source of incomparable joy: "the joy I feel while writing a story is beyond words."

As a literary citizen, Sriniwas has played multiple roles: creative writer, literary critic, anthologist, and editor. His editorial work includes Maithili Katha Sanchayan (published by National Book Trust, New Delhi, 2004) — a landmark anthology of Maithili short stories in Hindi translation — as well as Katek Dinak Baad and Parichy Shatak (on Madhupji). His critical writings include Badalait Swar (2011), Maithili Upanyas ki Aalochana (2021), and Vishleshan (2022).

# III. BIBLIOGRAPHIC SURVEY OF PUBLISHED WORKS

## A. Creative Works (Story Collections)

**1. Trikona (1986)** — A collaborative collection in which Sriniwas participated alongside other writers. This debut co-authored collection introduced him to the Maithili reading public. The title (Triangle) signals a structural and thematic interest in relational tensions.

**2. Adahan (1991)** — His first solo collection. Stories explore rural Maithili society: its superstitions, socio-political pressures, the exploitation of teachers, the condition of women. The collection established his hallmark of realism grounded in local idiom.

**3. Gamak Lok (2005)** — Perhaps his most celebrated collection. The title story, from which the volume takes its name, portrays a mother's nuanced psychology as her son climbs officialdom while his wife grows distant from village ways. Contains the widely-discussed story "Sinurhar," translated by Gajendra Thakur into English.

**4. Guna Katha (2014)** — A collection concerned with the ethics of relationships: filial duty, intergenerational tension, market values eroding moral ones. This volume earned him multiple awards in 2019.

**5. Mati / Maati (2021)** — His most recent story collection, described as engaged with the earth, ecology, and cultural roots of Maithil identity. The title (soil/land/earth) is emblematic of his concern for the organic connection between human life and landscape.

## B. Critical and Editorial Works

**6. Badalait Swar (2011)** — A critical study of changing voices in Maithili fiction. Translated into English as "Changing Voices." This work situates Sriniwas himself as an incisive reader of the tradition within which he writes.

**7. Maithili Upanyas ki Aalochana (2021)** — A systematic criticism of Maithili novels. Contains a research essay on the history of special issues of Maithili periodicals, a meta-critical contribution noted in Videha 424.

**8. Vishleshan (2022)** — Maithili literary analysis and compilation. The title means "Analysis" — fitting for a writer who has also functioned as his tradition's own critic.

**9. Maithili Katha Sanchayan (ed., 2004)** — National Book Trust publication; 38 selected Maithili stories translated into Hindi. A contribution to the canonisation and dissemination of Maithili fiction.

## C. Translated Work

"Sinurhar" (Sinurhar — Putting Vermilion on Married Women by the Host) was translated into English by Gajendra Thakur and published in Videha (Issue 21, November 2008). "Mati" ("Soil") was translated by Ashutosh Kumar Thakur and published by Scroll.in (September 2024). Both translations have introduced Sriniwas to non-Maithili readers.

IV. THEMATIC ANALYSIS OF MAJOR WORKS

## IV.A Gamak Lok (2005) — The Village People

This is Sriniwas's most socially engaged collection. The title story presents a household in which a mother toils to make her son an officer, but the son's wife, an "officer's wife" by disposition, treats the mother-in-law with barely concealed contempt. The story is not melodramatic; the mother's psychology is registered with extraordinary sensitivity. Chandana Devi writes in Videha 424: "His story — Gamak Lok — portrays today's environment with such detail: an officer's son's highly-ranking daughter-in-law, her mentality, and among it, how subtly the mother bears her feeling — the reader feels as if listening to one's own neighbourhood."

"Sinurhar," the collection's most discussed story, dramatises the return of a widow who has remarried — Kalyani — to her natal home for her brother's sacred thread ceremony (upanayan). The story's central tension: will Kalyani be allowed to participate in the sinurhar ritual, during which married women have vermilion applied to their hairline by the host family, or will she be excluded as a remarried widow? The mother is the barrier; the father is the ally. Kalyani ultimately asserts herself, quietly but decisively. Dr. Kailash Kumar Mishra reads this as a story that probes caste patriarchy, widowhood stigma, and female solidarity; Katna Jha praises it as still relevant in 2025; Dr. Dhanakhar Thakur offers a more critical reading, finding the story's progressive outlook somewhat limited by its focus on Brahmin widow-remarriage rather than divorce-remarriage, which is now the more common reality.

"Jamuniya Dhar" (Jamuniya River) is set in a context where a Muslim woman, Salma, whose wastrel husband has died of snakebite, is perceived by others as having moved on too quickly. The story shows Sriniwas working

across communal boundaries — Sootradhaar and his wife, the central observers, represent one consciousness, while Salma's grief and resilience represent another. The story demonstrates Sriniwas's capacity to render female interiority with empathy.

## IV.B Adahan (1991) — Burning / Smouldering

The title Adahan (lit. burning, smouldering) captures the suppressed, slow-burning nature of Sriniwas's social vision. In his interview with The Wire, he described this collection as exploring superstition, teacher exploitation, and socio-political conditions. One story, "Ekta Deg Lait Jingi Mein" (Taking a Step in Life), draws on his own experience of staying at a public school and witnessing the exploitation of teachers. The collection shows an early career rooted in witnessed experience rather than urban fantasy.

## IV.C Guna Katha (2014) — Story of Qualities / Merit

This collection explores what it means to have and to lose moral qualities (guna) in a marketised world. Dr. Abha Jha's analysis in Videha 424 notes: "The story Guna Katha reveals the decay of family relations and ethics in the context of market values — a son and daughter-in-law find even a mother's good deeds tiresome, while the grandchild, in place of affection, suggests keeping her at home for monetary gain." Jha connects this to the broader arc of Sriniwas's work as a chronicler of rural moral ecology under siege from urbanisation and materialism.

Other notable stories include "Baant Bakhara" (Division of Inheritance), which traces the trauma of a widowed mother after her husband's death: as her sons divide assets mechanically, she becomes a "pendulum" swung between households, and the story ends with a piercing exchange revealing her internal rupture. "Fatka" (The Untouchable's Rebuke) challenges the social diminishment of physically capable communities; the protagonist's retort — "I live my own life; wherever your esteem is not preserved, understand that the difference between you and me is precisely there" — is cited by Dr. Abha Jha as one of Sriniwas's most declaratory moments.

## IV.D Mati / Maati (2021) — Soil / Earth

In "Mati" (translated as "Soil" in Scroll.in), the protagonist Kamalnath returns to the ancestral village drawn by an inexplicable urge to wander. The story's dialogue — "I feel an incessant urge to wander all alone" — and its use

of the bael fruit anecdote (a small fallen fruit causing both pain and laughter) are characteristic of Sriniwas's method: the apparently trivial incident becomes a site for reflection on mortality, memory, and belonging. The earth (mati) is not metaphor alone; it is literal soil, the specific soil of Mithila that Sriniwas insists his characters must be rooted in.

### IV.E Critical Works

In Badalait Swar (2011), Sriniwas positions himself as a critic who reads changing literary voices as symptoms of social change. Gajendra Thakur's editorial in Videha 424 notes that Sriniwas's essay in Maithili Upanyas ki Aalochana (2021) — on the history of special issues of Maithili periodicals — contains a significant argument: that a living writer's evaluation published in a reputable journal is often more meaningful to the writer than even a Sahitya Akademi prize. This meta-literary claim, coming from a writer who has won multiple state-level awards but no Sahitya Akademi recognition (as of 2025), carries biographical weight.

## V. NARRATIVE CRAFT AND STYLE

Sriniwas's narrative craft can be characterised by seven distinctive features, some praised and some contested by critics in Videha 424:

#### *1. Grounding in Village Life*

His stories are overwhelmingly set in the rural Mithila countryside. Characters are embedded in specific social customs — upanayan (sacred thread ceremony), sinurhar (vermilion ritual), baant bakhara (division of inheritance) — giving his fiction an ethnographic density rare in contemporary Maithili writing. Devshankhar Naveen, in his essay "Uth Jaag Musafir Bhor Bhayo" (Rise, Traveller, Dawn Has Come), calls Sriniwas the first story writer who woke a sleeping society.

#### *2. Psychological Interiority Without Dramatism*

Sriniwas's characters are psychologically drawn but without melodrama. The mother in "Gamak Lok," the father Rambhadra Jha in "Sinurhar," and the widowed mother in "Baant Bakhara" are all rendered through restrained accumulation of detail. Dr. Abha Jha observes: "Though his stories lack fantastical elements or romantic flights, they stand firmly on the bitter, hard ground of reality." The editor Gajendra Thakur, however, finds

characters "one-dimensional" — good characters are straightforwardly good, bad characters straightforwardly bad — and sees this as limiting psychological complexity.

### *3. Observer-Narrator Positioning*

Several critics note that Sriniwas frequently adopts what Thakur calls the "Sanjay mode" — the detached observer position. The narrator watches the drama but does not enter it. Thakur sees this as limiting the stories' capacity to generate the deeper conflict that would make them transformative social documents. Katna Jha, by contrast, praises the narrative style as controlled and purposeful.

### *4. Regional Linguistic Authenticity*

Sriniwas employs regional Maithili vocabulary, idioms (kahabiyan), and dialect. Editor Thakur notes the relative absence of such regional vocabulary as a limitation — contrasting Sriniwas unfavourably in this respect with Dhumaketu, the Hindi/Gujarati story writer, whose stories are free of this weakness. Yet other critics value precisely this regional lexical thickness. Dr. Dhanakhar Thakur notes that Sriniwas sometimes uses "ya" (य) where "e" (ए) is more appropriate, a linguistic slip that detracts from stylistic polish.

### *5. Social Change as Theme, Not Agent*

Thakur's most substantial criticism is that Sriniwas's stories depict social change (widow remarriage, patriarchal customs, market values) but do not become vehicles of change — they observe without generating the moral urgency that would push the narrative beyond the local and familial. Thakur calls this the central limitation: "Sriniwas becomes a Sanjay — the observer — and the story ends in those small resolutions without deeper analysis." Whether this is a limitation or a considered aesthetic choice (realism over romanticism) is a debate the criticism itself generates.

### *6. Use of Folk Materials*

Sriniwas has also written children's stories based on Mithila folk tales (e.g., "Pandit O Unhak Putra" — The Pandit and His Son), demonstrating his command of the oral tradition. This folk-literary interface gives his work a mythic substratum even when he is writing social realism.

***7. Narrative Closure and Thematic Resolution***

His stories tend toward closure, often gentle and affirmative. Even "Sinurhar" ends with Kalyani applying sindur — a partial victory rather than a confrontation. Thakur finds this preference for small resolutions a structural weakness; others see it as honest social realism that avoids utopian wish-fulfilment.

# VI. WESTERN CRITICAL PERSPECTIVES

## VI.A Formalism and New Criticism

Applied to Sriniwas, the New Critical method — close reading for internal structure, imagery, and tone — reveals considerable craft. In "Sinurhar," the window from which Kalyani observes the ritual she is excluded from is a perfect structural emblem: the window represents simultaneously access (she can see) and exclusion (she cannot participate). The ending — Kalyani entering the courtyard and having sindur applied by a cousin against the mother's wishes — resolves the tension not through confrontation but through quiet solidarity. The "well-wrought urn" of the story is formally satisfying, though New Critics would note that the story's social argument somewhat overwhelms its aesthetic autonomy.

In "Mati," the imagery of soil — its smell, texture, the bael fruit — functions as an objective correlative (T.S. Eliot's term) for a complex of emotion: nostalgia, rootedness, the pull of origin. The story's minimalism is formally controlled.

## VI.B Structuralism and Narratology

Applying Gerard Genette's narratology, Sriniwas's stories operate in the homodiegetic mode (when the narrator is within the story world) and heterodiegetic (detached observer). The "Sanjay mode" identified by Thakur corresponds to what Genette calls the "extradiegetic-heterodiegetic" narrator. This choice limits what Genette calls "internal focalization" — intimate access to character consciousness. The consequence is exactly what Thakur identifies: characters are seen from outside rather than lived from within.

Vladimir Propp's morphology of the folktale is relevant to Sriniwas's folk-based stories. His retelling of folk narratives in "Pandit O Unhak Putra" follows the Proppian sequence of initial situation, disruption, quest, and

resolution — but inflects the didactic function of folk tales toward a modern concern with cultural preservation in the face of commodification.

## VI.C Postcolonial and Subaltern Perspectives

Maithili literature is itself a postcolonial formation: Maithili's recognition as a scheduled language (Eighth Schedule, 2003) came after decades of cultural marginalisation by Hindi-dominant nationalism. Sriniwas belongs to the first generation of writers who worked through the period of recognition, and his fiction — centred on village life, local customs, and regional idiom — can be read as a postcolonial insistence on the value of the marginalised culture.

Gayatri Spivak's question "Can the Subaltern Speak?" is relevant to Sriniwas's women characters. Kalyani in "Sinurhar," Salma in "Jamuniya Dhar," and the widowed mother in "Baant Bakhara" all occupy subaltern positions within patriarchal structures. What Sriniwas's stories show is not subaltern speechlessness but subaltern speech that goes unheeded — until the moment of narrative resolution. Kalyani does enter the courtyard; the mother does express her rupture. Whether this constitutes subaltern speech or is mediated by an upper-caste male author's imagination is a valid postcolonial critique.

## VI.D Feminist Literary Criticism

Sriniwas's fiction engages extensively with women's lives: widowhood, remarriage stigma, the psychology of mothers, the condition of daughter-in-laws. Katna Jha, in her essay on "Sinurhar," brings in Vibha Rani's feminist argument that the phrase "women are the enemies of women" (auraton ki dushman aurat) is itself a patriarchal construction designed to divide women and deflect analysis of structural oppression. Jha argues that Sriniwas's story implicitly concurs — the mother's exclusion of Kalyani is ultimately a product of internalised patriarchy, not female nature.

From a feminist narratological perspective, Sriniwas shows both strengths and limitations. He renders female psychology with empathy, but as a male author, his access to female interiority is always mediated. Dr. Abha Jha notes that the use of "vadhuk putan" (daughter-in-law) rather than a proper name for the daughter-in-law in "Manukhak Nahin Thik" creates "linguistic confusion" for readers — a small but telling symptom of how convention colours even sympathetic male authors' rendering of female characters.

# VII. INDIAN CRITICAL PERSPECTIVES

## VII.A Rasa Theory (Bharata and Abhinavagupta)

The oldest and most comprehensive Indian critical framework is the Rasa theory, elaborated by Bharata Muni in the Natyashastra (c. 2nd century BCE–2nd century CE) and philosophically deepened by Abhinavagupta in the Abhinavabharati (c. 1000 CE). The theory holds that literary art produces in the reader/audience a purified aesthetic emotion (rasa) by transforming the ordinary (vibhava-anubhava-vyabhicharibhava) into the transcendent.

Sriniwas's dominant rasa is karuna (compassion/pathos) — the emotional register appropriate to the sufferings he chronicles: widows excluded from rituals, aging mothers displaced by indifferent sons, communities losing their ecological and moral rootedness. But his karuna is tempered by shanta (tranquillity) — the stories rarely end in catastrophe; they end in quiet assertion or restrained acceptance. This blend of karuna and shanta is itself a sophisticated rasa-rasayani (rasa chemistry), producing in the reader a compassionate equanimity.

Vibhava (excitants) in Sriniwas are the social customs themselves — the sinurhar ritual, the upanayan ceremony, the inheritance division — which trigger the narrative tensions. Anubhava (consequent expressions) are the characters' restrained reactions. Vyabhicharibhava (transitory emotions) include shame, anger, love, and fear that shimmer through his characters without dominating the surface. This is precisely the aesthetic subtlety that Chandana Devi and Dr. Abha Jha praise.

## VII.B Dhvani (Suggestion) and Vakrokti (Oblique Expression)

Anandavardhana's theory of dhvani (resonance/suggestion, c. 850 CE) holds that the highest poetry works through suggestion — the unstated meaning that reverberates beyond the stated word. Sriniwas's narrative method is thoroughly dhvani-based. In "Sinurhar," the window image is charged with dhvani: it suggests Kalyani's position — seen but excluded, aware but voiceless, until she acts. The mother's silence after the cousin applies sindur to Kalyani — "The mother froze, uneasy" — is a dense dhvani moment: her discomfort, her partial defeat, her inability to protest publicly, all reverberate in that silence.

Kuntaka's vakrokti (oblique expression) — the idea that literary language achieves its effects through indirect, "bent" expression rather than

straightforward statement — is relevant to Sriniwas's characterisation of the mother in "Sinurhar." She never directly says she opposes Kalyani's participation; she says her son might be harmed. This vakrokti — the oblique voicing of patriarchal prejudice in the language of maternal concern — is exactly what Sriniwas reproduces in his stories.

## VII.C The Navya Nyaya Epistemological Framework of Gangesa Upadhyaya

Gangesa Upadhyaya (c. 1325 CE) of Mithila — notably, the same region that produced Sriniwas — is the founder of Navya Nyaya (New Logic), the most technically sophisticated school of Indian epistemology and logic. His Tattvachintamani ("Jewel of Reflection on the Truth") is divided into four chapters treating the four pramanas (sources of valid knowledge): pratyaksha (perception), anumana (inference), upamana (comparison), and shabda (testimony/word).

The application of Navya Nyaya to literary criticism is not conventional, but it is both legitimate and illuminating. Navya Nyaya asks: what is the structure of valid cognition? How do we know what we know? What are the conditions under which a cognition counts as knowledge rather than error or mere belief? These epistemological questions, applied to fictional narrative, become: how does a story produce knowledge? What cognitive structures does a story deploy? How does a reader come to know (or believe they know) the fictional world?

Gangesa's four pramanas applied to Sriniwas:

### *Pratyaksha (Perception) in Sriniwas*

Navya Nyaya's analysis of perception distinguishes between nirvikalpaka pratyaksha (non-conceptual, pure sensory contact) and savikalpaka pratyaksha (conceptual perception, which already involves categorisation). Sriniwas's narrative realism works primarily in savikalpaka mode — his descriptions of the sinurhar ritual, the village tola, the courtyard, are already conceptually organised, already saturated with social meaning. But he is also capable of nirvikalpaka moments: the smell of the bael fruit in "Mati," the specific texture of the clay platform in "Sinurhar" — these reach toward the pre-conceptual vividness that makes realism feel like direct perception.

Gangesa's analysis of perceptual error (bhranti) and its correction through subsequent perception is relevant to how Sriniwas's characters initially

misperceive each other and only gradually arrive at more accurate understandings. The mother's perception of Kalyani as an auspicious threat is a case of conceptually mediated perceptual error that Rambhadra's calm challenge begins to correct.

### *Anumana (Inference) in Sriniwas*

For Gangesa, valid inference requires a pervasion (vyapti) — a reliable general relationship — between the inferential mark (hetu) and the inferred conclusion. In Sriniwas's social world, the characters reason inferentially about each other: the villagers infer Kalyani's moral character from the caste and profession of her new husband; the mother infers inauspiciousness from Kalyani's widowhood. Sriniwas exposes these inferences as based on unreliable vyaptis — the "pervasion" that "widows bring ill-luck" is not a valid general relationship but a socially constructed prejudice masquerading as necessity.

This Navya Nyaya analysis of flawed inference — the hetvabhasa (fallacy of inference) — is exactly what Sriniwas's fiction dramatises. His stories present social reasoning as often fallacious, based on hetvabhasas (pseudo-reasons that appear compelling but lack valid pervasion).

### *Upamana (Comparison/Analogy) in Sriniwas*

Gangesa's analysis of upamana (knowledge through comparison) illuminates the intertextual dimension of Sriniwas's work. In Badalait Swar and his other critical writings, Sriniwas himself uses comparison extensively — comparing his stories to those of Dhumaketu, of Ashok, of Sushil — as the primary tool of literary evaluation. The comparative method is upamana-based.

In his fiction, comparison operates structurally: Kalyani's exclusion from sinurhar is made legible through comparison with her grandmother's remembered strictness. "Jamuniya Dhar" gains meaning through the implicit comparison between Salma's grief and the narrator's wife's failure to understand it. Upamana is thus both Sriniwas's critical and his narrative instrument.

### *Shabda (Testimony/Word) in Sriniwas*

For Gangesa, shabda — testimony, especially the word of a reliable authority — is the fourth pramana. Its reliability depends on the aptata (reliability, truthfulness) of the speaker. In Sriniwas's stories, shabda is dramatically present as competing testimonies: the village gossip about Kalyani's remarriage is shabda of low reliability; Rambhadra Jha's calm

defence of Kalyani is shabda of high reliability. The story's drama is partly a confrontation of competing testimonies, with the reader being invited to judge their reliability.

At the level of narrative authority, Sriniwas's authorial voice is itself a shabda — testimony about village life. The Navya Nyaya question "is this source reliable?" translates, for literary criticism, into questions about the author's access to the social world he represents. The Videha 424 critical discourse itself constitutes a multi-vocal shabda about Sriniwas's reliability as a social witness — with Katna Jha, Kailash Kumar Mishra, and Dhanakhar Thakur offering different assessments of the validity of his testimony.

### *The Navya Nyaya Concept of Visheshana-Visheshya (Qualifier-Qualificand) in Character Analysis*

One of Gangesa's most technically refined contributions is the analysis of cognition as structured by the qualifier-qualificand (visheshana-visheshya) relation, further mediated by the relation of qualification (samsarga). Applied to literary character analysis: a character is known not in isolation but as qualified by attributes — social position, relationships, actions, speech. The mother in "Sinurhar" is known not as an abstract psychological entity but as qualified by: her status as a Brahmin widow's mother, her fear of social exclusion, her love for her son, her internalisation of patriarchal norms. Gangesa's framework insists that we cannot separate the object of cognition from the relational structure through which it is known — a profound epistemological point that literary criticism often neglects in its rush to abstract character psychology.

This relational epistemology is actually more faithful to how Sriniwas constructs his characters than any individualist psychological analysis. His characters are always already socially embedded — known through their visheshana (qualifiers), which are their social determinants. This is not a limitation of his characterisation but its epistemological distinctiveness, and Navya Nyaya gives us the conceptual vocabulary to name it.

## VIII. COMPARATIVE LITERARY STUDY

### VIII.A Shivshankar Sriniwas and Kathakar Ashok

Kathakar Ashok (Ashok Kumar Jha, b. 18 January 1953, Darbhanga) is, along with Sriniwas, one of the defining voices of the generation of Maithili fiction writers who came of age in the 1980s. The two share a birth year, a

commitment to short fiction, and a relationship of mutual literary friendship — Ashok encouraged Sriniwas in his early career. Yet their aesthetic choices diverge significantly.

Ashok writes sparingly and selectively, producing fewer stories but of consistently high quality. His works include the story collections "Ohi Raatik Bhor," "Maatbar," and "Daddy Gaam," as well as the collaboratively authored "Trikon" (which included Sriniwas). Ashok's prose is polished, his endings are carefully crafted, and his stories demonstrate what the Videha 424 editorial calls "panchlain-ending" (punchline endings) — stories that drive toward a culminating revelation. His famous story "Chhala" (Deceit) was translated into English by Vishwanath Jha and included in The Book of Bihari Literature (HarperCollins, 2022) — evidence of his reach into English-language literary circuits.

The Videha 424 editor's comparative verdict is nuanced: "Quantitatively, Sriniwas has written more than Ashok, but Sriniwas is not the polished narrator that Sushil is. In quality, he is ahead of Ashok but behind Sushil." This hierarchy is debated, but it places Sriniwas in a productive middle position: more prolific and socially engaged than Ashok, but less technically refined than Sushil (Sushil Kumar) — who is praised in Videha 424 for his story "Masjid" (reaching "far beyond Baghotiya, far beyond Sinurhar").

The contrast in their narrative ethics is also marked. Ashok tends toward psychological interiority and the paradoxes of individual consciousness; Sriniwas tends toward social observation and communal dynamics. Ashok's observer is often implicated in the drama; Sriniwas's narrator more frequently maintains the Sanjay distance. This difference reflects the respective influence of modernist subjectivism (more present in Ashok) versus 19th-century social realism (stronger in Sriniwas).

Both are critics as well as creative writers. Ashok's critical work Katha Path and essays in "Maithil Aankhi" show a more formalist orientation. Sriniwas's criticism in Badalait Swar shows a more sociological orientation. Together, their critical works provide complementary maps of the Maithili story tradition.

## VIII.B Shivshankar Sriniwas and Kumar Pawan

Kumar Pawan is a Maithili writer associated with the younger wave of Maithili prose writers, known for a more urban and psychologically complex fictional voice. While detailed comparative critical literature on Kumar Pawan

in the English-language or Maithili secondary literature accessible for this study is limited, the broad contrast with Sriniwas can be mapped along several axes:

Where Sriniwas grounds his fiction in the rural Madhubani-Mithila world, Kumar Pawan's fiction more frequently engages with the rural-urban interface and the experience of Maithili speakers who have migrated to cities. This is a crucial distinction: Sriniwas writes of the village from within it; Kumar Pawan often writes of the village from the vantage of distance, whether geographical or generational.

Sriniwas's concern with social customs (sinurhar, upanayan, baant bakhara) gives his fiction an anthropological specificity that Kumar Pawan's more psychologically inflected fiction does not always pursue. Conversely, Kumar Pawan's access to the psychology of the diaspora Maithili — the migrant worker, the Bihari in Delhi or Bangalore — opens terrain that Sriniwas does not extensively cover.

The challenge noted about Sriniwas — that more Maithili writers are moving to cities and writing about rural life they have not truly lived — is precisely the challenge Kumar Pawan's generation faces most acutely. Sriniwas's distinctiveness, his advantage as a writer, is his genuine, embodied knowledge of the rural Mithila world that gives his fiction its ethnographic authority.

## VIII.C Sriniwas in the Context of Maithili Short Fiction

The IJCRT paper "A Critical Analysis of Maithili Short Stories: Twenty-First Century" identifies Sriniwas alongside Narayan ji, Indra Jha, Chandresh, Bibhuti Anand, Rambharos "Kapadi," Indrakant Jha, Ardhanarishwar, Virendra Jha, and Visnu Kant Mishra as producing "high quality" fiction characterised by "complete details of environment building, situation and characterization."

In the broader Maithili literary tradition, Sriniwas represents what might be called the "social realist current" — a tradition running from the early satirists like Harimohan Jha through the psychologically complex Rajkamal Chaudhary and the rural-rooted fiction of the post-Independence generation. He is not a maximalist like Jagdish Prasad Mandal (who has published fifty-plus story collections with a focus on lower-caste experience), nor an experimentalist in the manner of modernist Maithili writers. He occupies the solid, less glamorous middle ground of committed, careful social fiction.

# IX. CRITICAL RECEPTION AND HONOURS

The Videha 424 special issue (August 2025) is the most comprehensive critical assessment of Sriniwas's work published so far. Its nineteen critical essays, editorial commentary, and reader responses constitute a richly diverse evaluation.

Among the positive assessments: Naveen Shankar Naveen calls him the first storyteller to wake a sleeping society; Baidhyanath Jha praises his wonderful narrative craft; Dilip Kumar Jha argues that mati sachue saihe chaik (only soil is truly one's own) — earth is Sriniwas's deepest theme. Rabindranath Mishra finds him matchless. Kedar Kanth identifies him as a committed storyteller.

The more critical voices — especially Dhanakhar Thakur — note the limits of the "progressive" label for stories like "Sinurhar": widow remarriage, not divorce-remarriage, is the more common social reality in 2025 Mithila; the story's progressivism is historically located rather than contemporary. Thakur also notes the linguistic inconsistency (y for e usage). The editorial assessment by Gajendra Thakur identifies character one-dimensionality, limited narrative complexity, and excessive reliance on observer-narration as structural weaknesses.

His awards and honours include: Kiran Sahitya Samman (2013); Gauriknath Choudhary Lekhak Samman (2015); Acharya Yantranath Mishra Sahitya Lekhak Samman (2017); Punardehi Videha Sahitya Samman for Guna Katha (2019, Jharkhand Sahitya Manch, Ranchi); Maithili Sahitya Sanskriti Samiti Samman (2019, Madhubani); Dr. Ganapati Mishra Sahitya Samman for Guna Katha (2019, Chetna Samiti, Patna); Sahityiki Samman (2020); Shankuntala-Bhuvaneshwari Samman (2021, Hyderabad). The accumulation of these awards in 2019-2021, clustered around Guna Katha, confirms that collection as a high-water mark of his creative achievement.

# X. STRENGTHS, LIMITATIONS, AND ASSESSMENT

## Strengths

Social realism grounded in genuine lived knowledge of the Mithila rural world, producing ethnographically dense and culturally authentic fiction.

An empathetic but unsentimental rendering of women's psychology — widows, mothers, daughters-in-law — that gives female characters voice and dignity. A range that extends across village social ceremonies, ecological anxieties, intergenerational conflicts, market values, and communal coexistence. A dual contribution as creative writer and critic, offering the field both primary texts and critical frameworks. Linguistic engagement with regional Maithili idiom and vocabulary, preserving the spoken texture of village speech. Prolific output — five story collections, three critical works, an edited anthology — demonstrating sustained commitment over five decades.

## Limitations

Character psychology, as Thakur observes, tends toward the one-dimensional: characters are socially constituted rather than individually complex. Narrative complexity is limited by the observer-narrator's detachment, which prevents the sustained interiority that would give the stories greater psychological depth. Plot resolution often stays at the level of local, familial resolution without opening onto the larger social transformation the stories' premises suggest. Linguistic inconsistencies (y for e usage) detract from stylistic authority. The progressive social vision, while genuine, is sometimes dated relative to the realities of contemporary Mithila society.

## Overall Assessment

Shivshankar Sriniwas is a writer of genuine importance to Maithili literature: a faithful and compassionate witness to the social life of rural Mithila, a craftsman of quiet psychological observation, a critic who has enriched the theoretical self-understanding of the tradition, and an anthologist who has served the canonisation of Maithili fiction at a national level. He belongs in the first rank of contemporary Maithili story writers, though not — by his own implied admission in his criticism — without limitation.

Navya Nyaya's epistemological framework, which insists that knowledge is relational, contextually embedded, and always structured by qualifier-qualificand relations, is perhaps the most fitting critical lens for a writer whose deepest conviction is that human beings are known through, not in spite of, their social embeddedness. Sriniwas's stories produce knowledge of the Mithila social world not through abstraction but through the careful, contextualised accumulation of pratyaksha (perceptual detail), anumana (social reasoning, including its fallacies), upamana (comparative illumination), and

shabda (competing testimonies about social reality). This is, in the truest sense, a Navya Nyaya poetics.

## XI. CONCLUSION

Shivshankar Sriniwas's literary career — spanning five decades, five story collections, three critical works, multiple edited volumes, and an unflagging commitment to the social life of Mithila — is a significant contribution to Indian regional literature. He writes from inside a tradition (Maithili), from inside a geography (Madhubani-Mithila), and from inside a social world (rural Brahmin-Kayastha Maithil society), and he does so with the ethnographic fidelity that only genuine belonging can generate.

His work invites reading through multiple critical lenses. Western formalism reveals his care for image and structure. Postcolonial criticism illuminates his role in the affirmation of a marginalised language-culture. Feminist criticism shows both his empathy with women and the limits of male-authored female subjectivity. Indian Rasa theory identifies the karuna-shanta combination that gives his best stories their emotional signature. And Navya Nyaya — the epistemological tradition founded in the very region he calls home by Gangesa Upadhyaya of Mithila — provides a conceptual framework for understanding how his stories produce social knowledge: through relational cognition, the analysis of fallacious inference, the confrontation of competing testimonies, and the dhvani (suggestion) that resonates beyond the stated word.

Compared with Kathakar Ashok and Kumar Pawan, Sriniwas occupies a distinct and valuable position: more socially embedded and prolific than Ashok, more rurally rooted and ethnographically dense than Kumar Pawan. In the larger constellation of Maithili fiction, he is neither the most experimental nor the most psychologically complex writer, but he is among the most faithful and the most socially committed — qualities that the Videha 424 special issue confirms are now rightly receiving their full critical recognition.

The Videha special issue's dedication to him, the gathering of nineteen critical voices from across the Maithili literary world, and the ongoing translation of his work into English and Hindi, all suggest that his place in the tradition is secure — and that the critical conversation about his work is, at last, beginning in earnest.

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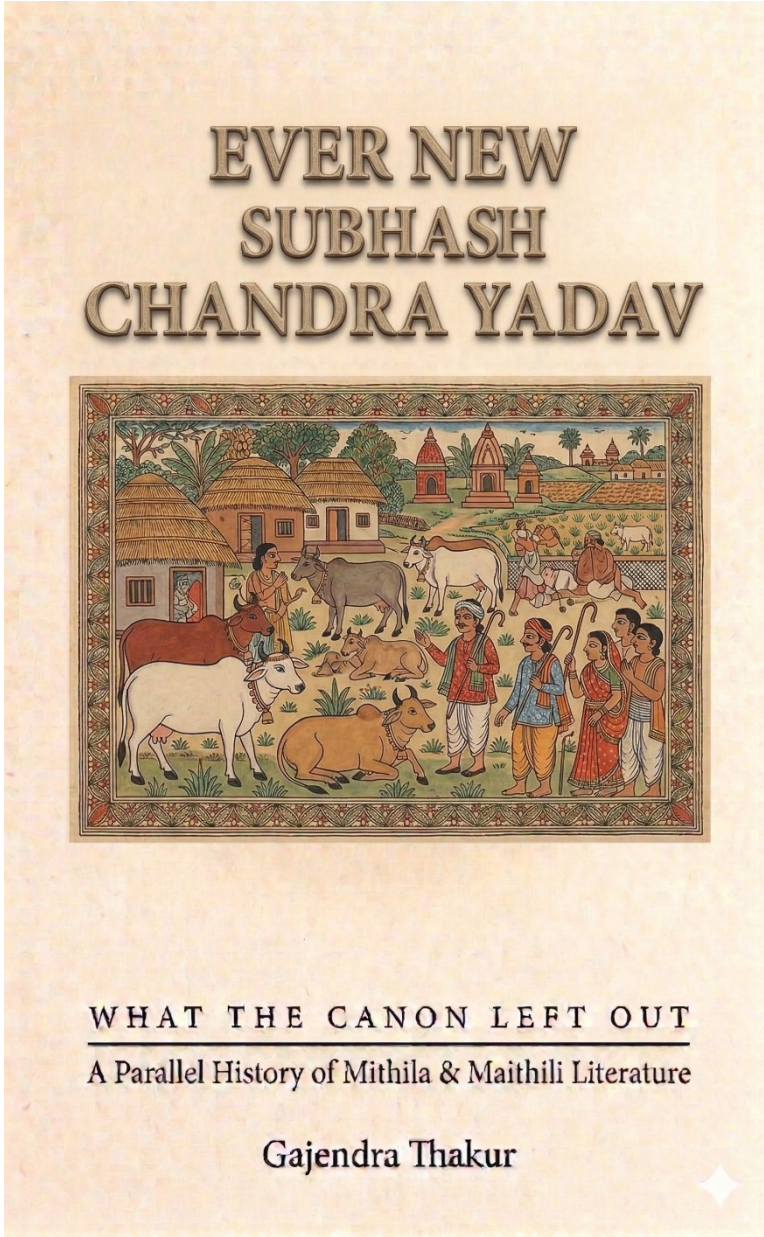
**LESSON 086 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**



## Nit Naval Subhash Chandra Yadav

Nit Naval Subhash Chandra Yadav (Writer's Block - The parallel stream of Maithili literature - The complete literature of Subhash Chandra Yadav)

The longitudinal relation pole of Julia Kristeva, The vertical relation pole of Julia Kristeva/ Jacques Derrida - Post-structuralism meaning deconstructive theory

Now come, let us do a close reading of all the original works of Subhash Chandra Yadav... Ghardekhiya

Nit Naval Rajkamal (Rajkamal Monograph)

Banait Bigadait

Gulo (Hindi translation)

Preface of Gulo "The Story of the Last Destitute Person" - Author Kedar Kanan

Gulo (Original Maithili)

Ramta Jogi

Madar

Bhot

Rereading of Ghardekhiya, Rajkamal Monograph (Nit Naval Rajkamal), Banait Bigadait, Gulo, Ramta Jogi, Madar and Bhot

Gulo: Art and Language

Nit Naval Subhash Chandra Yadav

(Writer's Block - The parallel stream of Maithili literature - The complete literature of Subhash Chandra Yadav)

Subhashchandra Yadav (1948- ), born 05 March 1948, maternal place Diwangunj, Supaul. Ancestral place: Balba-Menahi, Supaul.

Original Maithili writing first phase: Ghardekhiya (1983)

Original Maithili writing second phase: Banait Bigadait (in Videha e-magazine from 2008 to 2009, then in book form in 2009), Gulo (published in Mithila Darshan, 2014, then in book form in 2015), Ramta Jogi (2019), Madar (2021), Rajkamal Chaudhary Monograph (rejected by Sahitya Akademi in January 1997, in Rachna magazine December 2005-March 2006 issue and in book form in 2022 under the name "Nit Naval Rajkamal"), Bhot (2022).

"Those who listen to stories rule this world" - Hopi American tribe proverb.

And Subhash Chandra Yadav did not stop listening to stories.

"Swapnasundari and the Magical Birds of Mithila" (Geeta Dharmarajan, Katha, 1996)

The singing birds of Swapnasundari, the little princess of Mithila, were very pleased. But she would turn even fish, goats, and cows into birds. The subjects complained about the princess, the princess got angry and stopped making birds. She would not come out of the palace either. The remaining birds from the magical land of Mithila also disappeared. The farmers were still ploughing the fields, but without the colourful birds, this Mithila did not seem like that Mithila anymore. Then came the timber merchants. What is the use of a tree without birds? They convinced the people, cut down all the trees of Mithila and took them away. The farmers tried all kinds of tricks to save some trees, but

they could not succeed. Without trees, all the streams dried up. Without trees, the people became poor, and the timber merchants became rich. The farmers went to the princess, pleading and saying, Princess, please help us, we were wrong. Swapnasundari sat in her room, where on all four walls were paintings of colourful birds. Looking at those bird paintings, the princess of Mithila, sad, said – No, you all were right. Birds alone cannot keep us happy. But the farmers said – Without birds, we too cannot remain happy, bring those birds back, princess. But the princess was so sad that she could not perform magic. Then the farmers said – Don't worry, we will plant trees, and the singing birds will return. And this time, we will not let anyone cheat us. And the entire Mithila began to stir as if a drought had broken. No one had any respite, and they started planting trees, singing and dancing, and continued planting. And as the trees grew and went around, everyone started laughing and began to pat each other on the back. Working together made them happy. And because of this, the trees also grew well and quickly. And in the land of Princess Swapnasundari, Mithila, small and big trees began to smile everywhere. Magical music spread in all four directions. Birds of seven colors – red, vermilion, sky-blue, yellow, pink, and water-soaked like – were making their nests. The princess said to the farmers – Our children go to school, this has been our dream for a long time. The farmers said – Yes princess, if we had been educated, no timber merchant could have cheated us. But then came a dilemma. Some among the farmers said – But then who will do the household work?

Then the princess of Mithila ordered – Children should learn the work of girls, and girls should learn the work of boys. Everyone likes moving forward together. And Swapnasundari gave a bicycle to every girl who went to school. Swapnasundari understood – In the world, those who can move quickly from one place to another are happy, because that way they finish all their work quickly. The farmers asked – Can't we ride a bicycle? The princess said – Why not? Women should do the work they like. A few asked the princess – But where does money come from? But everyone hushed them. Does the princess do all the work? And everyone set up a big fair. Money was collected, and Princess Swapnasundari's school was built. The school performs magic, there children go and become like colourful birds. Why don't you come to the princess's school? The princess came to school one day, came the next day, and started coming every day. And then she said that the parents of the children should also come to school. And then the princess started doing magic again. But this time, she started turning only useless things into birds. And many colorful birds have

also returned to Mithila, without any magic. Everyone has taken one thousand books each in their lap, books that bring joy, red, pink, and sky-blue. Red, vermilion, yellow, pink, and water-soaked like – seven colors, because the sandy place has been taken over by green lush trees. And the birds are singing – Without knowledge, beauty is like a dried stream. And the Mithila of that little princess became the greenest and most cheerful country in the world. People even say that because of these birds, there is magic in Mithila's environment. And if we too happen to find such a place, where men and women can think big thoughts! Is this magical place near us? Isn't this place, where magical things exist, inside us ordinary people? If you find this place, wherever it is, then inform us at our e-mail address editorial.staff.videha@gmail.com.

Subhash Chandra Yadav did not stop listening to stories.

But he remained stubborn since 1983, some so-called lower-caste writers also went along with the imaginary spelling of Maithili and left him, they became victims of gaslighting. The timber merchants started pressuring from all sides. Like that little princess, he kept watching...

But from 01.01.2008, after 8 years of preparation, Videha – Maithili e-magazine started planting trees, in Mithila, side by side, and colourful birds started returning.

After 25 years of breaking his silence, Nachiketa started publishing "No Entry: Ma Pravesh" in Videha fortnightly e-magazine, and in that same year, after 25 years, Subhash Chandra Yadav started telling stories to Videha readers, side by side. Subhash Chandra Yadav's Ghardekhiya came in 1983, and after 25 years, "Banait Bigadait" was e-published in Videha in 2008-09 and then came in print in 2009.

"Those who tell stories rule this world" and the parallel stream is telling stories. Colourful birds of Mithila have returned like Sandeep Kumar Saffi, Umesh Paswan, Bechen Thakur, Kapileshwar Raut, Umesh Mandal, Ram Vilas Sahu, Rajdev Mandal, Nand Vilas Ray, Jagdish Prasad Mandal, Durganand Mandal, Acharya Ramanand Mandal, Lalan Kumar Kamat, Narayan Yadav, Munni

Kamat, Shiv Kumar Prasad, Dhirendra Kumar, Ramdev Prasad Mandal "Jharudar" have come with colourful stories and songs.

Everyone has taken one thousand books each in their lap, books that bring joy, red, pink, vermilion, water-soaked seven colors, and sky-blue. Because the sandy place has been taken over by green lush trees.

And Subhash Chandra Yadav started telling stories again.

After Banait Bigadait came Ramta Jogi, Gulo, Madar, Bhot. The Rajkamal Chaudhary Monograph rejected by Sahitya Akademi came under the name "Nit Naval Rajkamal". And thus Subhash Chandra Yadav is "Nit Naval Subhash Chandra Yadav".

Maithili Story Science (Maithila Kathashastra) and Subhash Chandra Yadav

The target of Michel Foucault's "Disciplinary Institution" and the psychological "Gaslighting" of Barton and Whitehead is the same. Michel Foucault's "Disciplinary Institution" is to bring the straightforward person into discipline and for that, make everyone fight among themselves, reward some, and gradually marginalize those who do not come into discipline. In gaslighting, the straightforward person is made to believe that what you are opposing is not opposition, everyone is doing it, you are opposing just for the sake of opposition to hide your own shortcomings. For this, the existing basic flaws in society are also utilized, and gradually the target becomes confused or flees.

So Subhash Chandra Yadav's writer's block was not ordinary writer's block, it was "gaslighting".

But in its opposition comes Story Science, which pre-analyzes what effect listening to a particular story has on people and society. That parallel stream decided to fight fire with fire. The mainstream writers who twist language in the name of standardization were working with the basis of gaslighting along with Story Science. Their objective was to call spelling variations errors. Ramdev

Jha, targeting Ghardekhiya, wrote that whoever fails to write properly in Assamese, how can they do so in Maithili?

And Subhashchandra Yadav got confused.

But when Ramanand Jha 'Raman' used this Story Science with Bisadh, and in its light, when Umesh Mandalji sent me the story of Jagdish Prasad Mandal, which was edited for spelling by Shivshankar Srinivas (he worked hard for three days to remove errors, he did such a favour too), my ears perked up.

Because by then, Subhash Chandra Yadav's stories with their spelling had already started being e-published in Videha. I explained the essence of Story Science to Umesh Mandal Ji and the version with so-called corrected spelling started being published in Videha [see Dudh-Pani Farak-Farak (Story and Manuscript Jagdish Prasad Mandal) - (Photo and Editing - Umesh Mandal)].

And Umesh Mandal informed that after spelling correction, Jagdish Prasad Mandal Ji had started feeling lost, and when he heard that the version with spelling correctness was rejected in Videha and his original spelling version was being e-published, new enthusiasm came in him.

Then when Umesh Mandal Ji's story met Subhash Chandra Yadav, Subhash Chandra Yadav Ji informed that the mainstream people just write something, they don't listen, they don't engage. He had great trust in Rajmohan Jha, Brother Saheb. "Then what is the solution?" "The solution is what you all are doing, meaning increase the number of writers."

And Story Science also says the same, that whoever tells stories rules, and whoever tells more stories progresses further. And thus Brihaspati is also false. But this time, in the second phase, Subhash Chandra Yadav is not confused.

And the parallel stream has been telling stories for 15 years and the mainstream is listening.

Whereas all of Michel Foucault's disciplinary institutions like Sahitya Akademi, Maithili Akademi, Maithili Bhojpuri Akademi, and the so-called literary associations recognized by Sahitya Akademi are with the mainstream.

But the techniques of gaslighting of all of Michel Foucault's disciplinary institutions and the mainstream, the technique of offering to be a guardian, have been ended by Story Science.

Story Science exposed Tarānand Viyogi's terminology (1) like novels being produced in Maithili in bulk, (2) language of the Mehtar caste, and (3) the conspiracy to pile up a mountain of garbage, and Ramanand Jha "Raman"'s terminology (1) "Language of the market" (in the preface of Dr. Pramod Kumar's 'Kanakirba').

These are all gaslighting techniques used to demoralize, which have been ended by the parallel stream with the help of Story Science. So this example proves that the mainstream has people of all castes, and so does the parallel stream. With the help of Story Science, alongside Brahminism, the neo-Brahminism of non-Brahmins has also been identified.

And this is the reason why the Sahitya Akademi attempted to suppress the story-listening event "All Night the Lamp Burns", and when it failed, Ramanand Jha 'Raman' and other mainstream people could not maintain their mental balance. Ramanand Jha 'Raman', crossing all limits, called me and Umesh Mandal without naming us in a Brahminical institution's magazine and told obscene stories, and as a reward for this, Sahitya Akademi, Delhi, recognized that institution as a so-called literary association. This incident shows the impact of Story-Science.

But Ashok is delighted that for the last ten years, the event 'All Night the Lamp Burns' has been organized by parallel stream writers, and he says – "Its initial purpose was to hold gatherings in villages, that is now happening." This story happened in our village in 'All Night the Lamp Burns' [story centered around Buddhist Siddha Mehtapa (Children's Literature)] in 82, where Shivshankar Srinivas also said – "When we started 'All Night the Lamp Burns', the purpose

was that it should happen in every village, but it started going around Patna-Chennai."

And Omhar Ram Bharos Kapari 'Bhramar' and Parameshwar Kapari were also stuck in Paya Pār, Nepal. Their works were not included in the collection of Indian government institutions because they were from outside (Nepal), but stories of another writer from that same Nepal, who was associated with a status symbol, were included. □

The longitudinal relation pole of Julia Kristeva, The vertical relation pole of Julia Kristeva / Jacques Derrida - Post-structuralism meaning deconstructive theory

The journey of stories – Vedic narratives, Jataka tales, Aesop's Fables, Panchatantra and Hitopadesha, and folk tales that have continued alongside. Everywhere, along with the stories of the elite class, folk tales exist, and so it is in Maithili too.

Regarding this, Subhash Chandra Yadav has the following thoughts:

"Very little work has been done on folk tales in Maithili. There are some collections of folk tales available, and they have been documented based on memory, not on field work. Any unit of folk literature can have more than one form, which can be obtained by doing field work. Only one form remains in memory, and considering it the best form can be wrong. The collection of folk tales done so far is incomplete. Some field work has been done for folk songs, folk narratives, and folk deities in Maithili, but hardly any field work has been done for folk tales. Now that the transmission of folk literature from one generation to the next is becoming increasingly endangered, its preservation is essential. Preserving folk literature is not only necessary because it is an object of the past; it also engages with the discourse of its time and self-reflection, and presents a paradigm. We all continue to use its metaphors, symbols, emotions, and craft in our own ways in written literature. Similarly, written literature also keeps influencing folk literature. Studies on folk literature have mainly focused on determining place and time. Questions related to its function, purpose, and meaning are still neglected. In Maithili, the study of folk literature has not even

properly begun. In the books that exist, the definition and list of folk literature are presented. Among the available collections of folk tales, there are more tales that came to Maithili due to transmigration. There are fewer folk tales that are originally Maithili, which can be called authentic Maithili. In the Maithili folk tales compiled by Ramlochan Thakur, which we have made the basis of this very brief study, there are very few authentic Maithili folk tales. The two tales we have chosen to express our views on the purpose and meaning of folk tales are – 'Ekta Burhiya Rahay' (An Old Woman Lived) and 'Ekta Chinama Khelai Rao Bhaiya' (Brother, Play with One Chinam). The atmosphere of both these tales is purely Maithili. The discourse, self-reflection, and paradigm of both are in accordance with the Maithili psyche. The discourse of both tales is centered on justice. In the first tale, the old woman challenges the plough, the king, the queen, fire, water, and the elephant to get justice, because the foot had stolen her lentil piece and was not giving it back. The discourse of the tale is expressed in poetic form like this – Elephant, elephant, elephant! Drink up the ocean, ocean. Ocean shall put out fire, fire. Fire shall scorch the queen, queen. Queen shall make the king understand, king. King shall punish the plough, plough. Plough shall cut the foot, foot. Foot shall give the lentil piece, lentil piece. What to eat, what to drink, what to take abroad. It goes on. The foot gets ready. Then out of fear of the foot, the elephant, out of fear of the elephant, the ocean, out of fear of the ocean, fire, out of fear of fire, the queen, out of fear of the queen, the king, out of fear of the king, the plough gets ready to do justice and the foot gives the lentil piece to the old woman. Ramlochan heard this tale from his mother. He said that in the version of his mother, the old woman would return from the elephant. While documenting it, he recreated it. In his documented version, the old woman goes from the elephant to the foot. Taking the old woman to the foot adds to the suggestion of the tale. But how appropriate is such documentation of folk tales? The self-reflection of this tale is expressed through the old woman. The reaction the old woman has to her situation is the self-reflection of this tale. The old woman threatens to go abroad over a lentil piece. She rejects the king and queen's offer of a measure of lentils. She does not take diamonds and pearls from the ocean. She keeps fighting for her right to the lentil piece. The implication is that one should have dreams. One should not be an object of charity. It is not good to accept alms. One should be self-respecting and fight for one's rights. The tale presents the paradigm that justice is achieved through struggle. 'Ekta Chinama Khelai Rao Bhaiya' (Brother, Play with One Chinam) discourses on the judiciousness of justice. Muniya (sparrow) is about to get the death penalty for the crime of eating one chinam. This discourse continues in poetic form, in which her dire condition is also depicted.

Brother with a beard!

Ploughing on the mountain

The children are dying of hunger

Brother, play with one chinam

And then they come to arrest you.

Then come the horse people, come the elephant people, come the poor people. Muniya pleads with everyone. They try to bribe the farmer; they are ready to give crops, horses, elephants in return for releasing her, but the farmer does not budge. When her life is about to end due to hunger and thirst, then he releases Muniya in return for the poor person. Muniya appeals to compassion and humanity. It is said in Manusmriti that silently plucking someone's flower is not theft; similarly, eating one chinam was not a crime. This is the self-reflection of the tale. The tale presents the paradigm that everyone's life is of equal value. The helpless and poor also have the right to live. There should be a space for them in this world."

The possibility of failure in a story is greater than in a novel, epic, or narrative, because a novel is a "soap opera" that runs for months and years, and at the end of every episode, it comes to a point and ends. Meaning, in a novel with seventy episodes, hope remains until the sixty-ninth episode that the story will take a turn, and if the direction of the story does not change until the end, then all the previous episodes are hits, and only the final episode is a flop. But a story does not permit this. It is a one-episode composition, and it is either very good or very bad.

If we go further ahead from stories and narratives, the history of the modern story-short story began in the late nineteenth century. It was considered to be in the forms of short story, story, and tale. Even the differences between these

three were unnecessarily explained. This journey, which began with Rabindranath Tagore, progressed as a result of a reformist movement from one corner of India to another. Bezbarua of Assamese, Fakir Mohan Senapati of Odia, Apparao of Telugu, Kedarnath Banerjee of Bengali – these writers sometimes came out in support of women, and sometimes against the moneylenders of society. In Nepali language, "Devi Ko Bali" was written by Suryakant Gyawali against the practice of animal sacrifice during Dussehra. Some stories were written against caste and wealth barriers within the bonds of love, while others were written on the condition of Dalit society and religious superstitions. And while doing all this, it was not always that the ending of the story was happy.

Isms: Literature: Postmodern, Existentialist, Humanist – these were ideologies of philosophy. Earlier, philosophy included science, history, socio-politics, economics, art-science, and language. But as the branches of science and art gained specificity, especially science, philosophy remained limited to mathematics and mathematical logic. The philosophical study system of induction and deduction moved towards an analytical system. Marx, who was like a divine intervention for the poor of the world, made the dialectical system the basis of his interpretation. Today's "discussion" or dialectic, which includes both pros and cons, was already present in the philosophy of disputation (as in Madhvacharya's Sarvadarshanasangraha). Francis Fukuyama, who declared the end of history – after the end of communist rule – later retracted from this. After the end of communist rule and the fall of the Berlin Wall, Francis Fukuyama declared that this was the end of history created by ideological conflicts, and now only the ideology of human interest would progress. But after some time, he changed his opinion and said that many different ideologies still survive within society and amidst nationalism. Similarly, the postmodernist thinker Jacques Derrida, by deconstructing language, proved that deconstructed parts depend on many different bases, and without understanding them, we cannot determine the meaning of language.

Post-modernism also stalled after its initial enthusiasm. Existentialism, humanism, progressivism, romanticism, sociological analysis – all these have survived by being incorporated into a synthetic system of criticism.

Psycho-analysis, due to being based on scientificity, has survived like the dialectical system.

What is a modern story? How should it be? Does it have some purpose, or should it have? And how should that be determined?

The basis of a story can also be psychology. The purpose of a story should be according to the needs of society, and the changes in the story's journey should be in accordance with the changes that have occurred and are occurring in society. But at the same time, the story is itself controlled by the culture of that society. And in this, the historical existence of that society becomes apparent.

If we talk about Vedic narratives, they bring forth love for the nation. And they teach living in harmony with society. Jataka tales, along with the spread of folk language, also carry the desire to spread Buddhism.

Stories from the Muslim world, like Rumi's "Masnavi", a distinguished text of Persian literature, teach the importance of knowledge and the advancement of the state.

Today's story encompasses all these things and moves forward towards the creation of an enlightened and humane society. And if it does not do this, then this should be included in its purpose. And only then can the analysis and criticism of the story become a reader's necessity.

Psycho-analysis and the dialectical method, like the analyses of Fukuyama and Derrida, have also been synthesized and remain a permanent paradigm for criticism.

For whom is the story written? Or told? Those about whom one writes, they do not read it anyway. Do people become enlightened by reading stories? The number of liars who eat the Gita's pledges is not small. So does the importance of stories written on such a criterion decrease?

If not everyone becomes enlightened, then at least they can get healthy entertainment. And if even one person thinks in that direction after reading a story, then the meaningfulness of the story is proven. And if those for whom the story is written are not the ones who read it, then those who are capable of intervening in that situation do read it. And as long as this is the case, such stories will continue to be written.

And as society changes, are social values eternal? In progressive stories, we reconstruct experiences, for a changing society, so that a balance between natural and social reality can be achieved. Or, is there a need for stories based on the permanent and fundamental elements of tradition to give stability to this changing time? There is a duality between individual interest and social interest, and both are opposed to each other. Coordination is necessary. A world view is necessary. A story is not just the creation of an idea that can be put on paper with illumination. It is directed by the socio-historical conditions.

So should a story be idealistic, naturalistic, or realistic? Or should it be humanistic, socialistic, or sensory-realistic that emphasizes experience? Or else, a story should be utilitarian. This includes utilitarianism, pragmatism, behaviourism, causality, functionalism, and consequentialism. This is the most modern perspective. Expressing oneself is human nature. But it becomes limited by social rules. It gets influenced by circumstances.

So a story is crafted by reconstructing experiences. And then individual consciousness can become social and collective consciousness. The oppressor has to control their own tendencies. Then the oppressed has to oppose this in an articulate manner.

Freedom – Social change. Then the story becomes communicable, becomes a medium of dialogue. A story can become a weapon for society only then, can become power only then.

Storytellers who preach are transferring knowledge, which is no longer necessary. When a storyteller starts a dialogue, then an atmosphere of freedom is created, and the participating reader gets relief from passivity.

A story achieves this purpose only when it is systematic and comprehensible. It becomes practical, not intellectual. The generosity of the Vedic narratives gave birth to dialogue, which the orthodoxy of Puranic literature destroyed.

And for the re-establishment of dialogue, the storyteller needs to have belief – logical belief and experiential belief, which Subhashchandra Yadav possesses. The analytical philosophy of positivism analyzes not the object but the linguistic statement and concept, which is evident everywhere in Subhashji's stories. Analytical or logical positivism and existentialism were born as a reaction to science. This clarified the ambiguous view of science.

In phenomenology, the datum of consciousness is studied in its given form. Sensation is the observation of the facts of specific mental activity. This is a medium to see the object in an absolute and pure form. In existentialism, man is only man. He is nothing apart from what he creates, he is condemned to be free (Sartre). Through Hegel's dialectics, through the endless interconnection of analysis and synthesis, emphasis was laid on deciding the quality of process and existence. The deeper the fundamental element, the farther it remains from form and closer to reality.

Quantum theory and the uncertainty principle have also influenced modern thought. The internal and external processes behind the apparent reality are possible through the exchange of tiny elements of power-energy. Through the principle of uncertainty, position and form have to be determined by estimation.

The hypothesis of a world with more than three dimensions and Stephen Hawking's "A Brief History of Time" are directly eliminating the existence of God because the concept of the death of God has also emerged from this, and now the existence of the controller of the universe is in danger. In the context of the death of God and the end of history, how long will Maithili stories keep telling tales? Will they remain engaged in analyzing short, very short stories (Beehani Katha), stories, tales, etc.?

Just as virtual reality brings reality artificially before us and merges consciousness with it, similarly, without hypothesizing more than three dimensions, we cannot reach the other side of the universe starting from the

Indus Valley Civilization. This sun is a medium-sized star among billions of stars. We, inhabitants of one city-village on a planet of that mediocre star, are worried with our hands on our heads, thinking whose problem is greater than ours? All these scientific and philosophical facts have come as a challenge before our stories.

Holistic or must coordinate totality! This philosophy becomes reality only when it comes from the philosopher.

Post-structural methodology does not connect the meaning of language, words, their meaning, grammatical rules, but rather the process of meaning creation. It holds different meanings for all types of individuals and groups. There is no ultimate connection between language and the world. A word and its text do not have a final meaning or their own specific meaning.

Regarding this, Subhash Chandra Yadav has the following thoughts:

"Expecting a writer to clarify and explain their composition is an unreasonable expectation. This is not the writer's job. No matter how obscure and controversial a composition is, the writer is responsible for it, but is not obliged to be its commentator. Why should a writer go around explaining their composition to everyone? Is this possible? If a writer wishes, they can establish some dialogue regarding their composition during their lifetime, but what about after death? The reader reads the composition according to their own understanding and discretion. Every age also has its own distinct understanding. So this diversity and changeability is an essential quality of every meaningful composition. Over time, the emotional significance of a composition keeps changing. So with the change of era, the interpretation of the composition also changes. In this way, no single composition has one uniform reading; the reading of a valuable composition is infinite. The writer does not have control over the text. So there should be no hurry to offer explanations and clarifications for this diversity of reading. Our own experience is that until an event is imbued with an artistic vision, it cannot be transformed into a composition. The reader grasps that initial vision in different forms and interprets it differently. It seems to us that even if a reader may not understand the vision and philosophy of a composition, they certainly grasp its essence;

they internalize its emotional elements. This becomes clearer with an example from folklore. 'Ekta Chinama Khelai Rao Bhaiya ... tae le pakrane jaae' – even if the reader may not understand the discourse and philosophy of justice and equality in this statement, they certainly experience the cry of the poor for freedom. Similarly, in our stories 'Nadi' (River) and 'Kaniya Putra' (Son of the Girl), even if it is not so easy to understand the vision of love as a life-giving force, the reader certainly experiences the feeling of affection. In literature, the real thing is this feeling or essence. Any idea (or philosophy) should reach the reader through the medium of emotion; not as a dull discourse or sloganeering. We believe that the foundation of religion and culture is love. There is no other emotion greater than love in this world. Our stories do not move forward with any ideological or ethical prejudice. They do express the conduct and ideas of their time, but they are not bound by them. Our belief is that art does not bring about any revolution. It changes the emotional attitude and perspective of human beings in a very subtle way and is a component of long-term social change. Nothing more than this. Any critic who approaches literature with any expectation or prejudice other than this (like the conscious obstinacy of Maithili), cheats themselves and deceives others."

Modern and postmodern logic, reality, dialogue, and the exchange of ideas gave birth to modernity. But then the neo-leftist movement came in France, and ideologies like nihilism and anarchism also emerged. All these modern thought-process systems were based on disbelief, outside their faith and concepts.

The interpretation of the meaning hidden in the text began in the context of space and time, and language was made a medium of play – Language Game. And postmodernism came as a critique of all these authorities and their validity and stratification.

In the computer and information revolution, the creator of a software creates it and puts it on the worldwide web, and that software continues to function independently of its creator, including some functions that its creator did not create it for. And some interfering software, like viruses, divert it, make it destructive. Then the antivirus for this virus is also a software that corrects it, and if it cannot be corrected even by that, then the computer's backup is taken and it is formatted – clean slate!

Capitalism was born out of the industrial revolution, and now in the post-industrial society, the importance of information and communication has increased over production, and the role of computers has increased in society. Mobile phones, credit cards, and all such items are chip-based. During the 2008 Kosi flood, Gaurinathji was trapped in the village, struggling for food, but his A.C. ticket was booked with a credit card. What other example is needed of the role of information and computers in Mithila's society? In Gulo, you also see the discussion of the business of charging mobile phones.

Deconstruction and reconstruction view the restructuring of the thought composition process, which is taking new forms in the post-industrial era. History is not ending, but traditional history has ended. State, class, nation, party, society, family, morality, marriage – all are being redefined. Many institutions have become fragmented and contextless due to so many changes.

Are there no good stories in Maithili, no good plays? Is there no grammar in Maithili? Where is analysis like panisoha (water snake) and panigar (water animal) in Maithili grammar? Unal, pavak – they all exist! This discussion was necessary in the context of Subhash Chandra Yadav's story journey.

When the problem of Maithili is its expulsion from home, when after trying their hand in Hindi and not getting a name, many people write stories and poems in Maithili and become editors and critics, filling the atmosphere of Maithili stories and poems with the burden of their ambitions, when Marxism, feminism, and secularism are being stuffed into stories and poems by chanting mantras, then the determination of standards is also being done in this way, and lack of standard has become a pretentious doctrine.

Those engaged in exploiting and demoralizing the poor and lower castes take refuge in Marxism, those who humiliated women take refuge in feminism, and those who are communal take refuge in secularism.

Even communal people have been seen taking refuge in feminism, anti-women Marxists, and such alliances and monasteries. If someone is engaged in praising Rajkamal, then someone is engaged in praising Yatri and Dhumketu, and they are putting themselves forward while taking whose side? Even today, Yatri's

Paaro and the stories of Rajkamal and Dhumketu have not been accepted – such nonsense talk!

Some are editing so-called controversial stories and creating controversy themselves to put themselves forward. Poets and storytellers are being distracted by a competition limited to Maithil Brahmins and Karana Kayasthas, and after leaving Hindi and coming to Maithili, with the speed they are doing these deeds, when will they focus on the main problems of Maithili? People also understand that after Hindi, if they write in Maithili, will they get acceptance quickly? If the creators of Maithili have such illusions and lack of confidence, distrust in the communicability of their mother tongue (!), then under whose pretense are we all conspiring to leave the future of this language on the shoulders of these people?

When there were twenty writers in Maithili and five readers, what controversy would have arisen? The Maithili writings of Rajkamal/Yatri are beautiful, we can say that after reading each of their compositions. In that situation – this controversy exists in this poem and in this story – bringing such talk and putting forward arguments in their favour to polish one's own writing?

And then after Yatri, the first novelist is so-and-so, and after Rajkamal, the first poet is so-and-so – now pairs of storytellers and poets are also appearing, in devotion to each other and to promote mutual disputes.

The main problem of Maithili is that this language is dying amidst the mutual ambitions of these limited competitors (destructive!). Poets and storytellers have made Maithili a career for themselves, made it an object of seminars. Then where are the readers and what controversy?

The problem we see is that children are not getting an environment of Maithili, and people of all castes love this language, so where are the stories and poems? How many science fiction stories, children's and adolescent stories and poems are careerist poets and storytellers writing?

Getting a hundred or two hundred copies of a book printed, having it reviewed, getting it published in magazines that print a hundred or two hundred copies, making folders of its photocopies and keeping them at home, applying for awards, and maneuvering to get the book included in the syllabus – our hopes in this environment have become fixed on non-Maithil Brahmin and non-Karana Kayastha readers and writers.

Those who cannot manage their own home and family have collected many language awards and are sitting, are engaged in building Mithila state – how will they manage the state if they get it?

They shamelessly take translation awards from Marathi, Urdu, Tamil, Kannada – they don't even come to ask the meaning of Vanakkam, they have no knowledge of Alif-be-se, they don't have the ability to talk to a child in Marathi. And they escape from this because in Maithili, their heads are hitting against each other, they themselves get printed and do reviews, there are no readers. The absence of readers benefits them. And in all these awards, when the jury and advisory board themselves come forward, the weak self-confidence of these limited competitors is apparent.

Those whose children have not entered literature, how can their discussions happen, how can their side be presented? There is a need to expose this truth of Maithili literature. The solution is being sought by closing their eyes.

Disciples and sycophants of editors of story, poetry, drama, essay collections easily get a place in the all-time collection of Maithili. The same is the condition of magazines. By cutting throats in personal ambitions, without readers, these magazines themselves are dying and killing Maithili. In such a situation, such ridiculous throat-cutting is natural in folk tales written without fieldwork in drawing rooms. Now even on the internet, caste-based throat-cutting and use of abusive language can be seen on some websites of Maithili.

Becoming Marxists and feminists, starting such business, and compensating for their own low level in this way has become a weapon for less-talented writers in the limited competition. Those who respect Marx, why do they call themselves Marxist critics or writers? Yes, what about those who do the business of Marx?

And its reason is also clear. National surveys show that in colleges, Sanskrit, Hindi, Maithili, and other literatures are studied by those who could not get admission in other subjects; in journalism too, these same people come. Such literature enthusiasts with poor talent are addicted to literature, and is the future of Maithili language safe in their hands? But beyond this reality, the path ahead awaits us. Sincere Maithili storytellers and readers who are ready to go into the dust and dirt, who create literature for children and women, and who invest their energy only in keeping Maithili alive – they are creating a category.

No compromise in the name of Maithili. This collection of Subhashchandra Yadavji was e-published serially in the e-magazine "Videha" (http://www.videha.co.in) and received the affection of thousands of readers, and these stories got online comments in which the majority of readers were non-Maithil Brahmins and non-Karana Kayasthas, as we guessed from their names. Here, it also became clear that due to lack of education, there is a difference in pronunciation and reading of the language. It does not mean that the language spoken in Balchanma is still spoken by Yadav Ji; now when he uses that language for the Yadav characters in his stories, it seems like the Prakrit used for the common people in Shākuntalam, and it was also felt insulting by people of that class. Language is dynamic, and the writing tradition brings stability within it. This difference is also clearly visible in Subhashji's language, between the language of his stories and the language of his essays, etc.

Julia Kristeva, in her presentation "Word, Dialogue and Novel", proposed the concept of intertextuality, meaning that a text cannot exist confined within one wall. So she calls the text a compilation.

Now look at Gulo, Nareshba gives one thousand rupees from Ranjita Ranjan for six votes. But he gets wiped out. Fulba Modi wins. It's an M.P. election.

So Subhash Chandra Yadav took note of the context of the text in 2015. They were churning inside him, and it came out in a detailed form in "Bhot" with an M.L.A. election in 2022.

So he establishes intertextuality with interdisciplinary subject matter. All these texts and subjects keep rubbing against each other and keep nullifying each other's influence, sometimes one text comes forward, sometimes another. And you cannot separate this text from the basis of society and culture. So the societal-cultural text and the literary text merge.

Text is a subject of practice and production. So pre-existing societal-cultural text and literary text produce two types of voices.

The text incorporates ideological conflicts and tensions.

In Julia Kristeva's longitudinal relation pole, direct dialogue happens between the writer and the reader. Meaning direct dialogue between the object in the envelope and the address written on the envelope. But in Julia Kristeva's vertical relation pole, the "text" dialogues with mainstream literature as well as with an event that occurred in a short period. Meaning dialogue happens between the text and its context, one writer's text dialogues with another writer's text.

When these two poles intersect, then a word or text is produced in which at least one other text can be read.

Julia Kristeva describes the right and duty of the writer as a form of preserving speech and dialect, and some text that is separate from human beings.

Julia Kristeva's presentation "Word, Dialogue and Novel" advances Mikhail Bakhtin's concept. At the same time, Julia Kristeva also analyzes language as a sign and symbol. When a child speaks with rhythm as a sign, there is no structure, no meaning. But when they grow up, they understand the difference between self and other, they start speaking and come out of the courtyard. And after that, they distance themselves from the mother. But they do not completely distance themselves from the symbolic; rather, they oscillate between the symbolic and the semiotic. The semiotic is feminine, associated with music, poetry, and rhythm; and the symbolic is masculine, associated with law and structure. So the devaluation of the female body and her character in

cinema, etc., by men is the fear of the mother's body threatening existence. But the baby child remains close to the mother, so they are more imbued with the semiotic feminine qualities, music, poetry, and rhythm; so they reject the mother but define themselves through her.

Cornell supports Jacques Derrida's intervention in feminist ideology through his phallus-centric deconstructive theory, and Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak welcomes it. As some philosophical ideologies indirectly give importance to the vulva, Derrida's drawing attention to the limitations of the phallus-centric view is a meaningful intervention, and it has become possible to redefine the components of the symbol under a process.

Derrida sees the impossibility of the factors of dialogue that take place; they cannot be simplified. Therefore, women should not be seen as objects of conjecture and knowledge. Feminism should not be seen in relation to masculinity; rather, there is a need to create a separate horizon for feminism.

So text, Derrida says, is broadly a political act that can be defined as a dialogue that takes place for power-relations. But Derrida is accused of wanting to appropriate the voice of women by men; with such effort for women that nonsense has been said, he wants to snatch that right to speak for themselves from them. Derrida is not concerned with the daily problems and powerlessness of women. Derrida takes the deconstructive method in a positive way and places feminism as a form of the duality of existential metaphysics/logic, like man-woman.

Derrida exposes the fascination with centre-based structures of Western philosophy. Structuralism, inspired by Saussure's linguistics, attempts a scientific analysis of cultural existence. Levi-Strauss's structural anthropology does the same for folk tales. Similarly, in literature, attempts at structural analysis for prose and poetry continue. But Derrida exposes this, structuralism seeks a concrete basis for its analysis, a centre outside the system from which it can scientifically analyze it, but that is just a philosopher's illusion. Meaning, how can there be a permanent or fixed structure of any folk tale? So to study the structure of a folk tale or narrative, you have to determine that idea or that centre based on which you want to analyze it. Derrida says that for any

structure, its conceptualization-idea is necessary, then you build it by joining pieces. But without considering the end, structure is impossible. And this is true in literature as well. As long as you do not assume a self-evident meaning for a composition, you cannot see its structure, because meaning, i.e., the end, determines its structure. So the structuralist already knows the meaning and then can analyze its various parts and their interrelationships. And this self-evident meaning known before analysis is Derrida's centre. And Derrida says that this determines how the text's structure is formed, which parts are included and which are omitted. So when we analyze the structure of literature and talk about its meaning and its impact, we are trying to identify and separate those elements responsible for that impact from that structure; we omit those possible patterns that do not produce that impact. So this centre is the starting point for understanding the structure. But this also limits the analysis. Because the centre creates stratification to keep itself stable, and controls it. And this prior knowledge of meaning also depends on the reader's prior history and contemporary critical theories and ideologies; all these are parts of culture, so how can they be kept away from the structure? They limit it, but are we not limited by them? So making a permanent centre the basis of our analysis is like giving a formula, and this is a reactionary or status-quoist position. And this proves only the desire to derive independent meaning from standard and non-comparative sources. So the illusion that we are seeing structure is an illusion; in reality, you are constructing structure from textual material.

So in Derrida's post-structuralism, initiation cannot happen without a centre, but through deconstructive analysis of this unproven self-evidence, he replaces that centre with another centre, but this new centre also does not remain permanent.

Similarly, Saussure, in his theory of sign, analyzes the sign: a word like "cat" is "cat" because it is not something else. So the word is the signifier, and what it signifies is the signified/object. But Derrida says that for this, you first need to bring a concept. And if you make the signifier absolute, that it has no relation to any signified, that it is an independent concept in itself, and it has no direct relation to any signified/object, then this concept goes beyond all signifiers and does not signify anything. And if we equate the signifier and the signified, then the grounding of the signifier is damaged.

So Saussure's theory is opposite to the logocentric when he says that you do not see any characteristic of the signified in the signifier. But when he says that the signifier is only used to denote the signified and is therefore subordinate to it, he appears to be in favour of the logocentric theory. So Derrida says that this clear distinction between signifier and signified is not valid, and the priority given to the signified over the signifier also needs to be overturned.

Meaning does not pre-exist in the signifier. And complete meaning is not found in any one signifier. So you have to wrestle with the text, and this pushes you towards an infinite search. So this signifier determines the signified based on its difference from other signifiers; the more difference, the closer you are to the signified. But this never means you can see all the differences. However, the signifier must have repetition, even though one signifier determines different signifieds. And for this, it is necessary to know the written history of that signifier. So the signifier gives different meanings and sometimes opposite meanings.

Derrida writes that from Plato to Saussure and Levi-Strauss, all writers prioritize spoken language over written, because writing is a medium, the real thing is speech. Saussure focuses on pronunciation errors in written form. But Derrida says that all the qualities found in speech are also found in writing. Furthermore, he says, the effacement of the signified in speech creates the illusion of the direct presence of thought. But if we record spoken speech and listen to it, it is also a chain of signifiers like written characters, in which different signifiers can be identified by their differences from each other. And writing can also be of two types: ordinary writing and writing done by understanding through pictures. 'The Metaphysics of Presence' lies behind all of this.

The main thing in the 'Metaphysics of Presence' of Western philosophy is immediate experience – but deconstruction says that no such experience occurs at the meta-language level, because this experience is identified through the medium of language. Furthermore, it is said that we understand the ultimate truth through divine consciousness, but deconstruction says that this is merely the creation of the creator. Also, that truth is hidden behind an object, but deconstruction says that no such independent existence exists; everything is

done by the system of creation and recreation. So Saussure's self-presence is nothing because everything is created within a system.

Derrida says that logic is the basis of all this philosophical thought; an ultimate truth and cosmic soul hypothesis is presented, which is omniscient. But Derrida says that this unproven centre has been called sometimes God, sometimes idea, sometimes cosmic soul, and it has created various levels below itself. So religion considered God as the ultimate truth, and considered man and other creations as imperfect, oppositional, and all these became centres that claimed to create ideologies according to themselves. But all these should be above the system. So God's presence should be independent of religion. Post-structuralist deconstruction considers the presence of such a transcendent truth as virtual, considering it the result of post-structuralist linguistic theory. So in the interplay of these signifiers, some meaning attains a higher status due to the intervention of some ideology, and its other meanings are pushed behind it. Ideologies like freedom, republic, justice are part of our lives, but it seems that many meanings have been derived from them, but upon investigation, they appear to be outside other ideologies. There is no concept that does not contain the remnants of other ideas.

See how Gulo's text begins; it begins with Tila Sakaranti, the courtyard is being plastered by Gulo's youngest daughter Riniya. Why did the novel Gulo begin with Riniya, not with Gulo's son? Because according to Julia Kristeva, the son distances himself from the mother, but the daughter, even when distant from the mother, has that rhythm, that quality, so she remains close to the mother, close to culture. This novel could not have had such a good beginning in any other way. Riniya is singing a song, then dew like water droplets, the westerly wind, and the mother's worry. "Go, wrap the sheet around you."

Later, there is a difference between daughter and son – "The girl is restless, sometimes at home, sometimes running to the orchard. The boy sleeps until eight o'clock."

And then comes Julia Kristeva's man, his arrogance. "If you don't recognize me, then recognize me."

Do you not see this arrogance in Lutyens' Zone? This arrogance is found everywhere. In human society, especially in male characters.

This situation of self-absorption by criticizing one's own stories and poems has come from the weakness of criticism. I have an aversion to this unique and first word, and its remedy I see in the "Videha" e-magazine's Maithili literature movement against the slow-poisoning given to Maithili. The way non-Maithil Brahmin-Karana Kayastha readers and writers united with children and women was wonderful. Some (Maithili) literary figures call our emphasis on this point an attempt to fragment literature, but our priority is Maithili, the Maithili literature movement; if this language is dying, then what is the use of the destructive editors-poets-storytellers-Mithila state activists-critics sitting in drawing rooms? The rereading of Subhashchandra Yadavji's stories and the rereading of his language attract us more. And here it is also relevant that the rereading of Subhashchandra Yadavji's fiction and language continues to come. And this event strengthens Maithili, which is hopeful. □

Now come, let us do a close reading of all the original works of Subhash Chandra Yadav... Ghardekhiya

Ghardekhiya contains 35 short stories. Among them, on number ten is 'Kathak Banal Lok' (The Man Who Became a Log), which was included in the syllabus of the 9th and 10th Bihar School Examination Board in the Galp Guchha story collection, and therefore this story is the most popular, read by more people than even the 'Ghardekhiya' story.

The publisher is Madneshwar Mishra, Chairman of Maithili Akademi. He writes that the class of people whose joys and sorrows, hopes and aspirations, indifference, anger, and social and economic background he has portrayed are still as neglected as before, and also that his stories are very poignant, his style is simple and clear, and his language is simple and understandable to all.

1

Abhav (Poverty) (1971)

The writer's attempt to write, to write poetry in different ways. Although Subhash Chandra Yadav does not write poetry, in this story written in 1971, he has written three short poems which are in no way inferior to the poems in the original and translated poetry collections that received Sahitya Akademi awards:

First Poem

On my arms and back
A tag was affixed
It had flashed like lightning.
And I kept trembling
And towards the direction of escape
From this corner to that corner
I kept running
Whichever room I went into
Its walls started blazing
Coming out of the room
The weather changed
And from the desert to the river and
The endless distance of the mountain
I kept measuring

Second Poem

Words were never given
Apart from the desired context
Making inaccessible mountains of meaning
I remained unsuccessful
In reaching anywhere
In a world full of suffering

The beginning of life

Third Poem

My reach is at that turn

From where

The meaning of words

Starts coming in a transformed form

But the poem did not progress further... then he thought that intense sorrowful passion was necessary for poetic creation. He tried to write satirical poetry but only expressed superficial anger.

This also applies to so-called satirists today.

2

Asangati (Incongruity) (1978)

Kuki made a sound... she had two cups in her hand placed on a tray.

'Are you going that side?'

Naveen felt a slight irritation – said 'No', but he kept feeling that Kuki, seeing his side, wanted to tell him to take the cups and put them away.

3

Aanchar (The Pallu/End of Sari) (1969)

Today again he did not feel like it – double satariya. If it rains in Asin month, every house has a cow and farmer. Its evening is also called – it neither barks nor growls, just sits and stares. Everyone targets his dried-up aanchar. Neither a daughter nor a son, what can he do. The sun had become harsh. It seemed as if the tulsi... then water had to be poured.

4

Uttar Megh (Cloud to the North) (1972)

5 guys: Mauji, Sheebu, Kaamu, Debu and Vijendra. The story progresses with all of them.

Three Maujis (women), three Musaharnis (women of Musahar caste), among them an old woman. The daughter of the irritated old woman. Many signs of neglect on the face. Due to lack of clothing and attention, both breasts were hanging, Sheebu, Kaamu and Vijendra were looking in that direction. A household quarrel, there is a husband too whom the old woman signals towards.

All five moved ahead towards the fair.

Then further on, an old man met... he had been spying for a certain master's wife.

Ahead, a middle-aged woman with a karakki (a type of bird?)... the Mauji was wearing a yellow sari and a red blouse... she went into a room with a man.

A family got off the train... three or four single girls... none of them are good! – Kaamu said.

What is happening around you and what you are doing for employment, most people do not understand this.

5

Ek Ta Dukhaant Katha (A Tragic Story) (1977)

Sugiya's husband had gone somewhere, she starts a relationship with her brother-in-law, she feels guilt. After a few days, everything starts again. Is it a sin or not a sin, confusion.

6

Ekta Prayog Ohina (An Experiment Too) (1970)

He has been sitting in the hotel for two hours, unable to make a decision, has already had tea twice. The sounds of discussions on education, politics, agriculture, unemployment, and many contemporary topics constantly strike his ears... there must be twenty paise in his pocket... a friend had given eight annas. The father-in-law comes and asks for paise... he never visited on that day in any season other than winter. His father-in-law lives in the same room. So in winter, he can sit on the terrace during the day. The mother-in-law sat down with a thick book of Hitopadesha.

7

Ek Ta Sambandhka Ant (End of a Relationship) (1976)

The game started... Pradeep, Ragini Datta and Vipul – whoever loses will treat to kebabs, the kebabs cost eight rupees... 'I' remained silent, didn't have money. Pradeep and 'I' on one side, Vipul and Datta on the other. Vipul was Datta's boyfriend, but his behaviour did not seem like a boyfriend to 'I'; it seemed strange and awkward.

8

Ek Dinak Ghar (One Day's Home) (1973)

Waiting for the train, when will the train come, and when it came, it stopped at the outer signal.

Small line and sometimes such incidents occur/have occurred on the big line train. At least in a bus, you know why it has stopped, but not in a train. Its psychoanalysis has been done.

9

Kalpit Mṛityu (Imaginary Death) (1970)

Dialogue between husband and wife, the wife has to go on the father-in-law's call. If the father-in-law gives money, then fine, but when he sets a time limit for returning, the husband gets distressed. And the wife says if she goes and he has an affair, and if the wife dies, then what relation does the husband have with the father-in-law?... will you marry my younger sister?

10

Kathak Banal Lok (The Man Who Became a Log) (1976)

This is the best story in the collection. Rami has to go to the Block, to get the fifty rupees for house collapse. Her son Badariya has become like a log, no matter how much you beat him, not a single response comes out, his eyes are sunken, all the bones of his chest are visible, his back hurts, he doesn't play, he looks blank as if thinking about something. But when Rami came at night, that Badariya, who had become like a log, asks – "Are you here, Babu? When did you come?"

• You are here, get up. Come, come, light the fire and come. I have just now arrived, son.

• Why didn't you come in the evening?

At his question, Rami felt all her sorrows and pains had melted away. She laughed freely for the first time in the whole day.

11

Kono Patapar (On Some Letter) (1974)

A letter from a foreigner, the mother of four children, with messages and complaints for his wife.

12

Gajkhor Aru Majmungar (Termite and Weevil) (1968)

In Bechni's in-laws' place, everyone calls her daughter-in-law a wanderer, and she too speaks like them; they call Bechni termite and her mother-in-law weevil.

13

Ghardekhiya (House-watcher) (1974)

Title story. Jagdish Prasad Mandal also wrote a story titled Ghardekhiya, which was e-published in Videha and compiled in the story collection Gamak Jīnagī (Village Life) (2009).

Bimala, it has been seventeen years, but she doesn't look her age, her face and ears are dried up. Seeing her, the potential grooms have come; everything gets done with low expense. The girl is pleased. The boy works as a khalasi on a freight train without brakes. The girl is pleased. The boy had come from Calcutta to the village in the rainy season; now as soon as he sends a telegram, the expenses for the wedding will be taken care of. He will come ten days before the auspicious date; whoever he has to see, he will see.

14

Chehrapar Jamait Kuhes (Mist Settling on the Face) (1972)

Protagonist and that girl. '... keep the door open at night.' The protagonist says, but forgets after saying it.

'Was the door open? Did the dog come inside then?'

'It was open!' The protagonist felt as if he could not believe it.

15

Chaubatia (Junction) (1969)

The protagonist is sitting in a hotel, feeling dizzy from hunger. He is going to the village; a separate story about uncle – for three months, he has been eating only rotis. He hasn't seen rice. The protagonist feels a desire – so many people have been piled up and still they can't control themselves. The uncle feels that the protagonist has a lot of money; he asks for money and tells the old man who sold the cloth that he sold it, if he gives it to him, then he asks for ten rupees. But the protagonist, due to lack of money, has to go hungry for two evenings. He leaves without eating, asks a friend for money; earlier he was a giver too, he asks for ten annas, but he doesn't give even a single paise. Another friend, Yadunandan, couldn't give one rupee for two years, he left from somewhere. The third is Kalicharan, but he doesn't say anything; then the hotel, he might have forgotten the money long ago, but there another guy is sitting... how comfortable is this chaubatia!

16

Jasoos Kukur Aru Chor (Detective Dog and Thief) (1973)

Theft, reporting to the police station and corruption, the daroga asks for money in the name of a detective dog... the dog catches the thief. The constable demanded 500 and settled for 300. But the dog?

17

Jhali (Mist) (1973)

Harvesting, Rāma felt like bathing today, she started feeling like vomiting. Gājā... in Dusadhtoli, a larāmāhā... four took it in their chilam (clay pipe) and flew away – Binduā says. The business of Dusadhtoli, women are there during the day and the sons-in-law spread coal at night. The men spend their days selling gājā, and the women at night. The inspector's son-in-law arrived... he took fifty rupees on the spot... the trap gājā makes one feel intoxicated very quickly.

In America, there is drug trade among African-Americans, does it look somewhat similar?

18

Tip (Tip) (1974)

What happens if you tip in a hotel, and if you don't?

19

Dar (Fear) (1969)

Analysis of the psychology of fear.

20

Tirth (Pilgrimage) (1969)

The story of the courtyard of Balbabāli. No doctor would tell her... but she tells. Since her arrival, ghosts have been haunting. 'Do you see Kusuma? Will her turn be like yours?' So Kusuma became Balbabāli. Four children, but in the marital home, they always got pounded rice and greens. Even when the brother-in-law didn't give money, she made her mother-in-law go on a pilgrimage, showed her. Asks the protagonist for some money, the protagonist has empty hands, no money. But what would Baijnathji do? What was the cost of one or two seers of chuda (flattened rice)? She showed the young brother-in-law. ... But it wasn't as if she was fine with all the harassment, so she didn't go.

21

Dhundhame Ghatna (Incident in the Fog) (1970)

First, second, third situation of the story, then two telegrams from the story compiler. And the final situation of the story.

In the first situation, whether it touches the feeling or not, east-west, atmosphere of tin houses, gulmohar trees, grass, doob (lawn grass).

In the second situation, evening, stake for the east wind, and cobwebs. Old, meaningless papers. After opening files all day, a man left the room for the market.

In the third situation, a woman who left the room before the story began, if she were to come now, what would happen, etc.

Before the final situation, two telegrams – first, a man afflicted with filaria – meaning swollen leg; second, a child born dead.

And in the final situation of the story, the road is called 'prostitute road', perhaps because its trampling happens. The feet are numb and heavy, but fragments of sentences for consolation keep forming. But the protagonist wants a crowd, light. But coming halfway and running away is useless.

Then the image of a dried stream, standing on its bank. Mist everywhere, no village, no people, no light; all these are present at a little distance in all directions, but now they are all useless, now fog and void like death.

Does 'Waiting for Godot' (Samuel Beckett) not come to your mind?

22

Dhukkar (The Wanderer) (1970)

The bus's starting time is not known. Does the bus stay here all day? Everyone cheats the conductor, the protagonist does too. Very few tickets are booked.

But then the conductor never meets the protagonist, perhaps he has quit his job.

23

Parichay (Introduction) (1971)

Netaji insisted that the protagonist go to his house; he felt that Netaji had given him socks, but when he got tired and left with his friend, the friend insisted on watching the evening show of the drama company, and there Netaji...

24

Pet (Stomach/Belly) (1971)

Kaleem! He gets lost in the crowd. He had called Vinay three hours ago, but he didn't pay attention. Hunger... he orders at the hotel, but only water gets served. The neighbourhood is quieter than usual. Someone has left a tap attached to the wall open, the noise is unbearable, but he also understands that there will be more noise in the morning.

25

Fansari (The Loop) (1969)

Bhelbabali's wife, over a hundred years old, eyes weak (probably cataract), only sees a little light. The image of Kartik month is also in this story. Harvesting happens in Agahan, one month before that, i.e., the 11th month after Agahan, very difficult, shortage of money. She goes to the protagonist, she is crying for lime for tobacco, has been crying since morning. For two or three days, she has been chewing only lime powder; if there was lime, no one would give it. The protagonist brought some lime and gave her, and also helped make her khaini. She is looking for her master (son), he was supposed to go to Supaul, but he is here, keeps breaking his head. The daughter-in-law feels she is being taught a lesson, cannot tolerate it. But the old woman's ears are also weak, she cannot hear. If she dies now, how will the feast happen, there are twenty-two problems – the protagonist says. The wife had been wearing a loop around her neck for three or four days; even if a wasp had stung her one day, she wouldn't have died; if the loop wasn't tight, how would she die?

26

Phukna (Trumpet/Whistle) (1970)

The protagonist is at his maternal uncle's village, but he cannot understand the two-coloured behaviour there. Coming from school, instead of playing, he was scraping the courtyard. When he cursed his brother's wife, she made him understand that she was not his younger brother's wife, she would make his face red with one slap. Grandmother saved him, but her ears and eyes were both weak. He started learning bicycle repairing, and his ballpoint pen disappeared. When the pen was found, in revenge, he bought three dozen phuknas (trumpets/whistles). Ravinder got some phuknas, he had ash in his pocket, when he didn't leave, he beat him. Father noticed. He asked grandmother – When will father come?

27

Baanjh (Barren) (1968)

Sawan month, the plate is muddy, the door and courtyard are all wet, the widow is singing. The first Sawan after the widow's husband's death, and she was left at her in-laws' place? – the widow's mother from Rampur asked. One and a half bigha land remains, even that the brother-in-law wants to grab. Husband's death, the hassle of the widow's marriage – a ramshackle hut, she kept the head of Sita's mother – kept it. Four were driven away, the widow's mother lay dying. By chance, the widow came back, that evening. The Rampur woman publicized it to another woman – it's happening to another – she said – whether you give cultivation or not, give bamboo. The widow left. The aunt had great respect for the widow there, but she did not understand the selfish motives of the uncle and aunt. But when the news spread, the aunt asked why her in-laws were not coming.

• They consider me barren.

The uncle and aunt wanted to get her land written in their name; if people asked, they would say it was spent on the marriage; the marriage expense would be borne by the old groom, and they would give five hundred rupees extra.

28

Ber-Ber (Again and Again) (1979)

Harivansh and Raghuvansh had bought first-class tickets for more than half the distance. Now they had to cross ten tīśanas (stations?). But Harivansh was caught by the T.T. He was imprisoned, but one day Raghuvansh came and paid his fine.

29

Mahima (Glory) (1975)

During a meeting, the police caught Sukhdev and took him to jail. He was released after a month, he had been caught in the Meesa (?) case.

He had been a Naxalite for a few days and had also spent eight days in jail before for cutting government stakes.

How many people did he cheat in the election?

There were many fights and quarrels; if not, they would thrash Narakatiyawali. After coming from jail, he got nothing, but took clothes worth four hundred rupees and returned.

30

Ramnihor (Ramnihor) (1975)

The mess helper Ramnihor used to send two hundred rupees every month to some woman in Faizabad district. He asked the protagonist for a holdall and went to the village on a ten-day leave; ten days passed, he should be able to come by evening; there is no need to worry so much about the holdall.

31

Lift (Lift) (1980)

Taking a lift from Mrs. Kapoor was a burden for Manoj, because Divakar knew her; why did Manoj get into the car with her?

32

Sanket (Gesture/Signal) (1974)

Room number nine has six seats. – If you ask her to get up, then you can spread the bed. Even then, someone might lie down.

33

Saharsa Dupahar Raati (Saharsa Afternoon Night) (1972)

Subhash, Mahaprakash, and Sukant. Sukant wants to escape the crowd, Subhash is indecisive. Mahaprakash doesn't have to think that much. Subhash wants to throw a cigarette butt on some girl's back. The police catch all three for wandering at night.

34

Sikaret (Cigarette) (1969)

Craving for a cigarette; he asks the servant, but he smokes the master's half and gives the rest. And an acquaintance, with some cleverness, a Wills Filter is found.

35

Surang (Tunnel) (1972)

Protagonist and Kishori Bhai reach Sheela and her engineer husband. Is the engineer suspicious of Sheela and Kishori Bhai? Why did Sheela start staying at her maiden home? Beni is one and a half years old; what revenge does she want to take by snatching milk and biscuits from an innocent child? He had read in the letter. But there, the engineer is playing with the baby.

The engineer works at the Lamp Works. Kishori Bhai bids farewell handing a sixty-watt bulb to the protagonist, but after going ahead, the protagonist learns that it is fused; he told him to bring a replacement.

Look at the themes of the stories in Ghardekhiya, look at the sketch of Badariya (became like a log, no matter how much you beat him, not a single response comes out, eyes sunken, all the bones of the chest visible, back hurts, doesn't play, looks blank as if thinking about something), stories about extramarital relations, the protagonist's poverty, his poverty-stricken life. In several stories, Subhash appears, and in one story, all three – Subhash, Mahaprakash, and Sukant [Saharsa Dupahar Raati (1972)]. □

Nit Naval Rajkamal (Rajkamal Monograph)

[Rajkamal Chaudhary Monograph (rejected by Sahitya Akademi in January 1997, in Rachna magazine December 2005-March 2006 issue, and published in 2022 under the name "Nit Naval Rajkamal")]

I had heard about the matter concerning Rajkamal Ji (monograph), it has been many years now. But it is so ugly that it became clear in your message. So for this, I thank you, Gajendra Ji. Actually, the truth is that even before reading the whole thing, my mind became 'disgusted'. Went ahead without reading! You did well by putting it on the net. The contemporary and future generations will also understand this dark story! Look at the irony of people like us that the entire matter is connected to my younger brother, friend, and elder. It has become such a historical accident! We are not personally responsible from any side. But the literary generation is cursed to bear "guilt" with morality. Solution? – With affection, Gangesh Gunjan 11 September 2012 (Videha 117)

The Rajkamal monograph was rejected by the Maithili department of Sahitya Akademi with the help of Mohan Bhardwaj and Rajmohan Jha in January 1997, and for this act, Rajmohan Jha was awarded the 1996 Maithili Sahitya Akademi Award in 1997. At the same time, to edit that act, Mohan Bhardwaj was made a member of the Sahitya Akademi's Maithili Advisory Committee.

Nit Naval Rajkamal (Life of Rajkamal) is dedicated to – Dharmapran Santosh Kumar Kundan Suvrata Girivar Krishn Radhe Radhe.

Nit Naval Rajkamal - The Hero of Legend

Rajkamal Chaudhary (Manindra Narayan Chaudhary, famous as Phool Babu) 1929-1967, Mahishi, Saharsa. Works – Aadi Katha, Andolan, Pathar Phool (novel), Swar Gandha (poetry collection), Lalka Pag (story collection), Katha Parag (edited story collection).

The descriptions of earthquake, Bengali sannyasin, and Raslila are based on Rajkamal's self-statement. Memories of the 1934 earthquake, the earth rumbled, and his parents, engrossed in their own concerns, abandoned him.

Then a few days after that earthquake, a Bengali sannyasin came; his mother had met that sannyasin at some pilgrimage. She asked him to come with her, and he too wanted to go.

He saw a painting of a Raslila – Krishna and some Gopis.

Rajkamal exaggerated all these stories. Everyone is looking for some excuse for their own personality/ideology. This was also a marketing strategy for Rajkamal.

Nit Naval Rajkamal - Life

Nothing special. First wife had no children, so second marriage (Rampur Haveli is Rajkamal's maternal home). Mother's death and father's second and then third marriage with a young girl of his age. Rajkamal called his father Madhusudan Chaudhary "Lal Kakka". From the third marriage, a daughter, Madalsa, survived; he had affection for her. Father initiated him into Brahminical rites through orders, advice, and beatings. Even before passing matriculation, Rajkamal had memorized all the verses of the Gita and Durga

Saptashati. He kept moving here and there with his father's transfer; enrolled at B.N. College in Patna from Nawada; his father gave him 442 prohibition mantras about what not to do.

Love affairs – first love affair in Patna with Shobhana Jha. Failed in I.Com once, then failed in B.Com once. Married Shashikanta of Chanpura (Darbhanga) in 1951. After B.Com, education ended.

After marriage, worked as a proofreader in some newspaper in Patna for a few days, then as a Lower Division Clerk in the secretariat. Darbhanga, Patna, Delhi, Mussoorie, then Calcutta. From there, correspondence with Savitri Sharma of Mussoorie; married her in 1956; then fell in love with a woman named Santosh (probably Savitri's niece); abandoned Savitri, who was pregnant, on 3 July 1957 and fled from Mussoorie. Then Patna, Darbhanga, and Nawada for three or four months, then Calcutta, with a letter for Yatri in the name of Hindi writer Chhedilal Gupta. Got associated with Babu Saheb Chaudhary's Mithila Darshan. Then worked at Bharatiya Jnanpith (Calcutta), he was with his wife. Then left the job and started Rāgarang Bahār, but it closed down. During his six-year stay in Calcutta, he wrote a lot of literature. His body weakened; the lump on his stomach started in Calcutta.

Then Delhi.

Correspondence with Kirti Narayan Mishra, Jivakanth, and Hansraj.

Then in October 1963, he settled in Patna.

1966, Shashi, Divya, Mukta, Nilu came from Nawada to meet him.

Correspondence with Alka of Varanasi, his last love affair. In the first week of November 1966, he went to Varanasi to meet her.

The communist critic Namwar Singh did not find it appropriate to send a postcard; in Nai Kahaniyan, a statement by Madhukar Gangadhar was

published that Rajkamal was undergoing treatment for his illness; he was asking people for money by making excuses of poverty and neglect. He wrote a letter and also provoked Prakash Jain and Manmohini, editors of Lahar. Rajkamal wrote in his diary – Madhukar & Lahar people have joined hands in dirty propaganda against me.

One day, Dr. Chaturvedi told him that he might have urethral cancer, and if that happens, the penis may have to be cut. Rajkamal wrote in his diary – If I have to cut my penis, I will commit suicide.

Chandramouli Upadhyay provided the most service, both individuals, even financially; long after Rajkamal's death, both Chandramouli Upadhyay and the other individual committed suicide. Rajkamal's deha-gāthā is dedicated to these two individuals. Hansraj and Alok Dhanwa used to visit him in the hospital. Rajkamal's four brothers lived in Patna; three brothers also had jobs, but none of them bothered to send even money for medicine.

Died in June 1967.

Nit Naval Rajkamal - Maithili Literature

Rajkamal wrote one hundred poems, three novels, thirty-seven stories, three one-act plays, and four critical essays. Swar Gandha collects the poems written during his Calcutta stay from November 1957 to April 1958. He considers Yatri as modern but not contemporary. Rajkamal wrote novels Andolan, Pathar Phool, and Aadikatha. Lily Ray's colorful screen reminded him of Emile Zola's novel Nana. Ramanath Jha, due to his traditionalist thinking, declared the entire craft of Rajkamal's literature as artificial. □

Banait Bigadait (Making and Breaking)

In most of the stories of Subhashchandra Yadavji's "Banait Bigadait" story collection, it is found that the story, more than a tale, moves forward with a theme and ends upon completing its function. Another specialty is its language. The language of Balchanma is the autobiographical language of the protagonist

of that novel, but here this language is the storyteller's own, and in that sense, it takes on a unique form. On one hand, against the tradition of the story adopting a didactic tale-like form, Subhashji's method of moving with a theme within a limited scope, paying attention to the craft of language which is pure native, gives a section of readers immense pleasure in the stories of this collection; at the same time, readers who couldn't come out of the tale-narrative tradition are not disappointed by this story collection; rather, it refines their taste.

Some language standardization contexts – like aich, achi, a i ch. During the time when standardization was happening, it was necessary to pay attention to this. Like "jāit rahī" was written as "jāti rahī" and then rules of pronunciation were made for jāti (jā i t), similarly aich is included. But now it is too late; the writer uses it in Kaniya-Putra to show direction, but reverts in other stories. But this at least proves the need to fix a standard form, and if "chhai" is to be written, it's fine, and if "chhaik" is to be written, then a pronunciation rule that the 'k' at the end is silent. But the urgency to make it quickly and acceptable to all is understood; today's people do not have the time to argue over writing 'ya' or 'e'; whatever the phonology says, accept it; 'y' is a consonant, 'e' is a vowel; using one universally in place of the other is impossible. If it is not acceptable, then make pronunciation rules. Writing "nañi" for "nahi" is understandable, but among "naim" (Antika), "nain" (N.B.T.), and "nãi" (Sāketānand - Kālarātirśca Dāruṇā), the usage of Sāketānandji proves more appropriate according to phonological principles; if you don't trust that, take help from phonetic laboratories.

A special feature of the book "Banait Bigadait" is that Subhashchandra Yadavji has used his distinctive writing style, which is phonetic and capable of advancing the standardization dialogue.

Subhashji is a storyteller of the post-independence generation. He gives form to life through stories. He adorns the story with both craft and content to make it meaningful. The struggle of ordinary people for existence is naturally found in his stories. The Badariya of his story "Kathak Banal Lok", written decades ago, would laugh at times. All the characters in this story collection have such unique qualities. A character, after waking up from sleeping while crying in the hospital, starts crying again; another falls in love. Some have business sense, while there are characters like Harivansh who, in return for a favour, end up

doing a disservice due to a system fault. Now, let's take a deep look at the stories in the "Banait Bigadait" collection.

Kaniya-Putra (Girl's Son) – In this story, a child on the road rubs the writer's feet, then places its head on his lap and is carefree, as if placing its head on its mother's lap. No hard object seemed to have hit the writer. This girl's chest is wet. The girl remains unperturbed, as if touching her father, grandfather, or brother. The writer thinks, is this Sita becoming, or Draupadi? Suspicions of Ravan and Duryodhan surround the writer.

After reading Kaniya-Putra, one sees the same crossroads on the road and children while driving at traffic lights. But now the vision changes. Whether wiping the car's glass to give money to begging children or not giving, but moving ahead without thinking – does reading Kaniya-Putra not change that perspective? The boy will grow up and steal or become the lowest rung of some drug cartel, but the girl? Will she become Sita, or Draupadi, or Amrapali? The social institutions, human rights organizations, which, on the threat of someone dying by climbing an electric pole for love, spread their net below to publicize themselves and their organization on TV cameras – can they work with that outdated view after reading this story? The government, which changes the name of a hospital to Jai Prakash Narayan's name or Harding Park to Veer Kunwar Singh's name and considers its duty done, will it reach the root of the problem and build new parks and hospitals and name them after Jai Prakash Narayan and Veer Kunwar Singh, or put a stamp of "Made by Me" on work done by others? Do these institutions still not stop the tendency to survive with minimal effort and seek easy solutions?

Asurakshit (Insecure) – After getting off the train, the 20-minute walk home at night has become so insecure that this story paints a vivid picture. It wasn't like this before – this is the people's mental state. But where is anyone's attention to such problems? The media's attention is on big problems, liberalization, and many other issues. A new perspective is emerging on such problems at squares and crossings; in this, the distance from station to home becomes like a mountain in the darkness of night. This is a kind of comment on the then law and order situation in the state.

Ekaki (Alone) – In this story, Kusesar is in the hospital. A detailed description of the hospital is given. There, a woman, after her husband's death, practically fell asleep crying and then started crying again when she woke up. This is how it happens. The storyteller points to a reality of human life and comments on the hospital's talk and management, not by directly stating it but by showing its vitality.

Wo Ladki (That Girl) – In this story, among the lives of hostel boys and girls, a young man named Naveen sees an empty cup in a girl's hand, which belongs to that girl and her boyfriend. The girl asks Naveen where he is going. Naveen feels that she asked him to throw the cup, assuming he is going the same way. Naveen refuses. Thoughts keep swirling in his mind. This story is based on a small incident... did she ask me to throw the cup because she assumed I was going the same way? And he moves ahead firmly without saying anything. Like 'Ekaki', this story is also based on psychological analysis.

Ekta Prem Katha (A Love Story) – Previously, those who had phones at home, others' calls would come to their home; they would just forward the call. The writer had a phone at home, and when a call came for a lover from his beloved, he used to forward it to the lover. The lover bought a mobile phone, so the calls stopped. But when the lover changed his number, the beloved's calls started coming to the writer's home again. The beloved is Ritu, a friend of the lover's cousin; the writer becomes worried about helping her. In this story, lover-beloved, mobile phone, and telephone all appear naturally in a new story with the new age.

Banait-Bigadait (Making-Breaking) is the title story. Three named characters: Mala, her husband Satta, and granddaughter Munniya. The usual mother-in-law/daughter-in-law issues of the village remain, like asking if they have eaten after bathing, etc. But when the son and daughter-in-law go outside, the mother-in-law becomes worried about the crow's call. This story depicts the reality of the village after migration. One day, along with Satta, the crow also disappeared, and Munniya kept looking at the crow and her grandfather. The story of migrants, of son, daughter-in-law, and granddaughter, of mother-in-law/daughter-in-law quarrels and love!

Apan-Apan Dukh (Each Their Own Sorrow) – In the story, the wife, in her situation of neglect, curses her daughter and son. Having to feed daughter and son at night, the wife having to stay hungry when the barn is locked after eating, and consequently getting angry at the husband's blustering voice – it's natural. Everyone has their own world. People think that their world's joys and sorrows alone are complete, but that is not true. Everyone has their own joys and sorrows, their own hopes and aspirations. The storyteller reveals such truths that come within his experience. How can the autobiographical experience be independent of the environment, and this is evident in all of Subhash Chandra Yadavji's stories.

Atank (Terror) – In the story, the storyteller meets an old friend, Harivansh, at the office. The writer's work of filing didn't get done because after Harivansh's transfer, no one took a bribe from him and therefore did not do his work. The reason for Harivansh's forced bribe was money; why would others give up their own money? The writer is terrified. The office environment, corruption, and changing social relations due to one person's transfer are all expressed here. When we or you go to the Block or Secretariat for any work today, we hear the same thing: just give whatever money is demanded, and if there's any problem then say! And if we take someone's name or recommendation in exchange for money, the employee will neither take the money nor will your work get done.

Ekta Ant (An End) – In the story, upon the father-in-law's death, the writer's brother-in-law has cut his hair, but the writer has not; there are various discussions about this. The brother-in-law, having cut his hair, is carefree. This cultural symbolism has come – whoever is caught is the thief and the wrongdoer, whoever is not caught is the idealist. Not completely, but in this story too, such beliefs are born and broken. In Haryana, when a father dies, people do not cut their hair; does that mean there is any lack of sorrow? In Punjab, women do not wear vermilion or bangles for a year after the husband's death, but bangles are filled until the first death anniversary; does that mean after the first year of marriage, their love for their husband decreases?

Kabachhu (Massage) – In the story, the masseuse comes to the writer, puts her hand on his thigh. Due to the writer being surrounded by people of upper-caste culture, he removes her hand. The masseuse says, what is the hesitation in touching the body that is touched. As if the masseuse was explaining to the

writer that she had mistaken him for a young woman. The writer feels she is a woman and the masseuse is her old friend. The masseuse does not understand the subtlety of place and time; otherwise, the writer would have had a massage even in this heat. There is regret over the masseuse's helplessness, but also disgust at her 'she-e-e' thought. Freud's psychoanalysis has been heavily criticized for centering on sex. But from experience, it is clear that the more distance you create from sex, the more you keep it away from conversation, story, and literature, the more intense its attack becomes.

Karbar (Business) – In the story, the writer meets Mr. Verma, Sinha, and two others. In the bar, Sinha, distinguishing friendship from business, tells two tales. Everything has a price; after buying a TV for a friend's wife, the discussion of the demand for a fridge ends in between. In the second tale, a woman goes to her ex-lover to pay the doctor's fee to save her husband's life. The ex-lover, in return for giving money, asks to spend the night with her. Sinha does not find anyone at fault in this story; why would the doctor treat without taking money? Why would the ex-lover give money for the engagement? And if the woman does not spend the night with the ex-lover, her husband will die.

Now when the writer comes out of the bar, the guard's salute also starts sounding like the clink of money. The breakdown of ancient values, friendship, and ideals gives a feeling of loneliness.

Kushti (Wrestling) – In this story too, Freud appears. The story begins with a dried, hard stain on the lungi. But it immediately becomes clear that it is not a semen stain, but a scar. Then, at the market wrestling match, discussions about village problems arise; the health centre being closed, the theft of bricks there. The younger brother, in the course of treatment, moves from allopathy to homeopathy; this is discussed. People come to ask about each other's wounds, and the writer tells everyone in detail, but ignores some who are younger in age; all this creates an atmosphere.

Kainari Ailaṇḍak Larel (Laurel of Canary Island) – In the story, Subhash and Upiya are characters. Here there is an image – like the decision is like the erosion of the Kosi. The cousin brother's letter, going for a bath not having taken a blade, coming to the stream of ochre water, getting off at the bath ghat,

and water up to the thighs even after the bath. Seeing someone pushing a bicycle on the sandy bank, someone says – "Did you get the bicycle from your in-laws? Make a sound like a big bullock." Didi and Pisa heard the discussion there, that the marriage of their daughter was delayed by two days because of the coat, and also that highly educated people become confused. Subhash cannot even ask for two hundred rupees, Didi's behaviour is ambiguous, Subhash is not assured and returns.

Trishna (Thirst) – In the story, the writer meets Akhilan. He recounts the details of his meeting with Shrilata. After returning on the fifth day, he did not meet her on the train. Now what does Akhilan do? Keeps roaming on the route between Visakhapatnam and Vijayawada, or spends his days with memories.

Analysis of small emotional incidents is present in the stories "Kainari Ailaṇḍak Larel" and "Trishna".

Dana (Grain/Seed) – In the story, Mohan has gone for an interview. There, a compassionate peon informs that outsiders are not taken; if one has a Ph.D., then it's a different matter. Everything seemed sick and sad to Mohan. Fuddi and Maina kept chirping and pouncing on the bread crumbs. The story sensitively describes the concept of outsider vs. local in competitive exam interviews.

Drishti (Vision) – In the story, after education is over, searching for a job, the sharp remarks of the villagers. Then, inspired by a South Indian journalist, starting farming in the village despite the opposition of the girl. Despite having a common theme, these stories reveal social truths here and there. Here, there are the intrigues of villagers, which arise due to excess free time in the absence of work. Also, the contemporary woman's aspiration to live an urban life is displayed.

Nadi (River) – In the story, the theme moves along with the story and ends. Bihari has come to Gagandev's house. He has to stay with him in the city for a year. While searching for a house with him, Gagandev meets a girl. Even after knowing that he would not meet her again after moving ahead, he was filled with joy and the feeling of love.

Pralay (Deluge) – This is a story of the flood, of the Kosi. Bauku is waiting for the boatman. But the water in the stream is rising. The Kosi flood is rising and the mother is in a bad state due to diarrhea. The goods and family are struggling with hunger. Ramcharan's house has plenty of food and water; he tells them not to make unnecessary arrangements. Bauku's house is a short distance away. Death and destruction have made Bauku hard, have broken his attachments. But the rain stopped. Bauku started trying to identify and remember his belongings.

Baat (Talk) – In this story too, the storyteller traces the path of his plot and progresses it with craft. Hearing an argument between a Neebo seller and a person at the Neebo shop, the writer intervenes. A person is asking the Neebo seller for his umbrella, which he had kept below. The sad thing, according to the writer, stays in people's minds for a long time.

Rambha (Rambha) – The changing relationship between man and woman is described intensely in this story. As long as the man stays away from the woman, everyone appears to him as Menaka and Rambha. But when dialogue begins, later the writer feels she is a daughter. A woman appears on the road. The writer thinks – who is she, Rambha, Menaka, or...? She has a son with her, not very handsome, because his groom isn't handsome. In the gossip, she sometimes calls the writer her father-in-law, sometimes calls herself his daughter. Initially, the writer felt bad. But later, he liked it. But in the end, he could not understand whether he should bow to touch her feet or become straight without touching.

Hamra Gam (My Village) – In the story, the path to the writer's village, the description of people from Katniya to Menahi village teasing and cutting wood in the middle of the embankment. People of the Kosi area – like animals, in the condition of animals. The writer's house in Katniya was cut, so he stays at Nathuniya. Nathuniya is used for fishing and trapping birds. There is a land dispute; one sharecropper's land has been submerged in the stream, so he wants to grab the writer's wheat field. People are harassed by the shadow and by women (!).

The writer has fallen for the woman without reason, like Vishnu Sharma falls for Shudras and women in Panchatantra while telling stories.

As long as everyone drinks tea around Kamal's place due to lack of cups, after harvesting the crop, you go to Siban. When there were forests of Jhao, Kas, Pater, birds used to come a lot; now they come less. Khariya, deer, fish, Kachu, Doka are all getting extinct – the means of livelihood are becoming scarce. In the evening, the panchayat on the land is happening. Satta's goat has died; the daughter-in-law says it's because of the mother-in-law's curse. The mother-in-law says to sell the goats because the sacrifice went wrong. The writer sees the rise of Satta's daughter's youth as a sign of male contact, and falls for the woman again, because this belief is common among people. Satta's daughter is not staying at her in-laws' place now. While eating at Sukhan Ram's place, the writer felt hesitation, to overcome which he said – "Today I will make your caste." The Kosi has wiped away all distinctions; Dom, Chamar, Musahar, Dusadh, Teli, Yadav all draw water from the same pitcher. They sit on the same platform. □

Gulo (Hindi Translation)

Based on the text of the Hindi translation of Gulo (Antika Publication).

First, comments on the Hindi translation of Gulo. (For theoretical discussion, see my book – Maithili Samikshashastra ka Maithili ke liye Ekta Anuvad Siddhant aur Anudit Sahitya ka Samikshashastra, available in Videha Petar http://www.videha.co.in/pothi.htm).

If you have seen a hit film like Kannada's "Kantara" in P.V.R., can you watch it on an O.T.T. platform in five minutes?

Just as Rajmohan Jha was saddened and held his head after seeing the Hindi translation (by Vibha Rani) of Harimohan Jha's "Kanyadaan", and author Vikram Chandra was sad after seeing the poor web series adaptation of Sacred Games by Anurag Kashyap, we had a similar feeling after seeing the Hindi translation of Gulo.

Mainstream people translate without reading translation theory; when the Brahminical and neo-Brahminical writers of the mainstream are dried up of vocabulary in original writing, what can they do in translation? Translator Raman Kumar Singh has neither Maithili vocabulary nor Hindi. In his newspaper-like language, in the very first line of Gulo's translation, he translates "Tila Sakaranti" as "Makar Sankranti"! Do the Brahminical and neo-Brahminical writers of the Maithili mainstream not use Makar Sankranti, and could Subhash Chandra Yadav not write "Makar Sankranti" instead of "Tila-Sakaranti" in the first line of Gulo?

So if you wish to read Subhash Chandra Yadav's Gulo in both Hindi and Maithili and want to see the application of gaslighting theory, read the Hindi translation first, then the original Maithili. Because if you read the original Maithili first, you will have the experience of watching a film in P.V.R., and if you read the original Maithili first, you won't be able to read a single page of the Hindi translation, and then how will you see the use of gaslighting? I want you to see this experiment.

In this context, it is necessary to discuss the 2021 Sahitya Akademi Award in Maithili, given to a non-savarna for the first time. Jagdish Prasad Mandal's novel "Pangu" begins where Yatri's Balchanma ends, and mainstream people started struggling, wondering how Jagdish Prasad Mandal moved ahead of Yatriji, and why are they falling behind instead of moving ahead of Yatriji? In 2018, this novel was e-published in Videha in 9 parts and compiled in Videha: Sadeha 21 (p. 677-779), then it came in book form the same year, and now it is also available in Videha Petar. The Hindi translation of this book was done by Rameshwar Prasad Mandal (Pallavi Publication), and my request is that you read this Hindi translation after reading the original Maithili; you will be able to read the entire book. The original and Hindi versions of Pangu are available in Videha Petar.

Now back to the Hindi translation of Gulo, how the translation happened and how the insider view of Maithili became an outsider view in the Hindi-translated version due to the use of translated story-science of neo-Brahminism, is shown in the table below. In many places, due to the scarcity of Hindi vocabulary, instead of a word, a description is given, which is also often

incorrect, and in many places, translation is not done at all, or literal/verbal translation is done while distorting the meaning.

| Original Maithili "Gulo" | Translated Hindi "Gulo" |
| --- | --- |
| तिला-सकरांति | मकर संक्रान्ति |
| एक्के ससपेन मे मुँह तोड़ि | एक ही सस्पेन से मुँह तोड़ |
| ओकरा टांसलकै | उसका घी बनाया |
| घरनियो\ | पत्नी भी |
| टुकदुम-टुकदुम | किसी तरह |
| कबइ कबई | मछली |
| दबिया | दाब |
| देखबहक छौड़िए! | देखेगी तू, |
| देलियह | आपको दिए |
| अमाठी | आम की टहनियाँ |
| करची | बाँस की छड़ियाँ |
| कठुआयल | स्तंभित |
| दाब-दाब करैत रहै छै | दबाव बनाए रखते हैं |
| बात उनटा दइ छै\\ | बात को पलट देती है |
| पनिजाब | पंजाब |
| मुँह बाबि कऽ | हताश |
| सड़लाह खुट्टा | घुन लगे खूँटे |
| उपरेलक | ढूढ़कर लाई |
| गज़न | इज़्ज़त |
| ओगरइ-ए | देखभाल करता है |

| रमराहड़ि | अरहर |

| ठिठुआ\\\ | ठिठुआ |

| कोय लटेलक | कोई उसे हथेली पर रगड़ता है |

| भाकन | जलकुम्भी |

| परचारै छै | ताना देती है |

| भोटिया | सुजनी |

| भोमहैर लेतै | काट खाएँगे |

| हपकुनियाँ | उंकडूं |

| चास, समार आ चौकी\\\ | चास, समार और चौकी |

| टोन करइ-ए | टुकड़े-टुकड़े करती है |

| पांगय लागल | काटने लगा |

| खराय | डंठल सूखकर सख्त |

| गोसांइ डुमानी | सूर्य डूबने |

| पछड़ैत-पुछड़ैत | किसी तरह |

| सिदहा | भोजन की सामग्री |

| गुलो उकटि देलकै | गुलो ने कहा |

| जुमा कए | निशाना साधकर |

| हपसि-हपसि | हाँफ --हाँफ |

| भासि गेल | हिल गए |

| पाढ़ि | छप्पर को टेकनेवाला आधार |

| हटहट | पत्थर |

| गिरहत | गृहस्थ उदार था |

| छील-मोठि | छीलकर |

| हड़ौथ | हड़ौथ बाँस |

| खढ़ | फूस उड़ गई |

| कालीबंदीक सेवा | कालीबंदी की पूजा |

| कुशक कलेप\\\ | कुश का कलेप |

| पाट | अंतर्धान |

| आरा | बगीचा |

| गाछी | आम के बगीचे |

| गैढ़ | काटकर |

| छौड़ी कए समांगे ने होइ छै | उसकी तबीयत ठीक नहीं है |

| टाट | घास फूस से बनी दीवार |

| दोसर बिछेलक | दूसरी बनाने लगा है |

| आलन | अस्तर |

| जैराठो | जड़ें |

| दू गो सुपारी नोत मे आयल छै | निमंत्रण की सुपारी मिली है |

| बाछ्य लागल | अलग करके रखने लगा |

| टिरसि कए | गुस्से में |

| कननमुँह | रुआँसा |

| बीट लगाएत | बाँस रोपेगा |

| सिसोहि लेलकै | तोड़ ले गया |

| अरिकंचन\\\ | अरिकंचन |

| लाट मे झुनियो रहै | झुनिया भी थी |

| अढ़े-अढ़ | चुपके से |

| नौ बजे राति मे | दस बजे रात में |

| ओलैत | चुनता |

| झखइ | अफसोस जता रहा |

| डंगेलक | उसे तैयार किया |

| टपय | आने |

| जोगतै | रखवाली कौन करेगा |

| सात-आठ टा नभका खुट्टा काटि | खूँटे काट रखे |

| खिखिर | नेवला |

| पजोठने | लेकर |

| हाक दाए | बुलाकर |

| जुआयल\\\ | जुआया हुआ |

| गलि कए भात भाए जेतौ\\\\ | गलकर भात हो जाएगा |

| तुम्मा\\\ | तुम्मा |

| अवाच कथा | बुरी बात |

| भूमकम\\\\\ | भूकम्प |

| भूकम्प\\\\\ | भूकम्प |

| ठठरी\\\ | ठठरी |

| ऊक | मुखाग्नि |

| हिन्नू | हिन्दू |

| करइ छै केना | बोलता क्या है |

| अरबा-अरबाइन\\\ | अरबा-अरबाइन |

| झोड़ा | बटुआ |

| टानि कए | लेकर |

| अखरा\\\ | अखरा |

\Subhash Chandra Yadav uses "gharaniyo" for wife, and Jagdish Prasad Mandal uses "bhansiya". The usage is different in two situations. Does the translator use the word "wife" for both?

\\ Turning the matter around is done, here it is giving a twisted answer.

\\\ Not translated

\\\\ Literal translation

\\\\\ Meaning-based translation

In the Hindi version, the chapter divisions are also not apparent; in the original Maithili, a new page starts with details, and where there is empty space, a picture is placed to indicate the chapter division.

Denmark's dictionary is very extensive, often in more than 23 volumes; immigrants often fail the Danish language test required for citizenship. A woman who was married to a Dane said the language paper is very difficult; even Danes fail it. The small population or area did not harm the Danish vocabulary.

As Hindi expanded its geography, its vocabulary did not expand accordingly. In America, there is a "high frequency" list of 350 words and a "basic word list" of 3500 for high school students, which doubles by the time they reach college and graduate school (where postgraduate is called graduate school) for non-language faculty students. For literature students/literary writers, it is expected to be ten times more than this. In Hindi, except for exceptions, which the leading Hindi figures mock as regional novel/writing and somewhat deny, Hindi poets and novelists create literature (poetry, novels) with a vocabulary of 2000 words of the eighth grade, and some Maithili writers want to remain limited to this basic 2000-word list, whereas Japanese characters number up to 500.

In a language where Ramlochan Sharan completed a Maithili version preserving the essence of the 14-15 thousand line Shri Ramcharit Manas in 1968 (V.S. 2025), such a Hindi translation of Gulo in 2021 (V.S. 2078) is distressing. □

Preface of Gulo "The Story of the Last Destitute Person" - Author Kedar Kanan

Before the beginning of the original Maithili Gulo, there is a preface titled "The Story of the Last Destitute Person". This is the cannon fodder of the mainstream, and this time the burden of that cannon fodder is on Kedar Kanan's shoulders, and it was written on the day of Tila-Sankranti!

But Subhash Chandra Yadav never wrote the story of the last destitute person. This preface is a malicious attempt to push Subhash Chandra Yadav's writing to the other side. He wrote the biography of Gulo Mandal, that Gulo Mandal who says –

"Do you recognize me? If you don't recognize me, then recognize me. I am Gulo Mandal. My house is on this square. If you have messed with me, then understand. I am Gulo Mandal."

And Kedar Kanan is messing with Gulo Mandal.

"Those who speak in big, high-sounding words are considered to be corrupting the language." – Kedar Kanan writes.

But Kedar Kanan does not have the courage to name those who use big, high-sounding words.

Kedar Kanan takes all benefits from the Sahitya Akademi and Maithili Akademi from those who use big, high-sounding words. And now when those big, high-sounding word users are on their deathbed, some have actually died, he wants to show himself separate from them.

And if the children of the big, high-sounding word users call Kedar Kanan, Veena Thakur, Ashok Avichal, and others who receive lakhs of rupees worth translation/editing assignments and Sahitya Akademi's children/translation awards ungrateful, that is their internal matter. But it is true that all these things came to them through the grace of the ancestors of the children of the big, high-sounding word users.

Also, if you do not use big, high-sounding words, or wear pants-shirts instead of dhoti-kurta, or are neo-Brahminical, then you automatically get the rights of all fraud, which is evident from Kedar Kanan's preface.

Gulo was published in 2015 with a preface by Kedar Kanan Ji.

The 2019 Sahitya Akademi translation award was given to Kedar Kanan Ji for his Maithili translation of the Hindi poetry collection "Akal Mein Saras" (author – Kedarnath Singh). Now you first tell me, are there people who cannot read a Hindi poetry collection and need its Maithili translation? And in this, Kedar Kanan got a double benefit of translation assignment and award, didn't he? Because in Ramta Jogi (2019), Kedar Kanan is absent; in Madar (2021), there is no preface.

But in Bhot (2022), Kedar Kanan has written 8 lines on the back cover – but there is not a single revolutionary line in it, why?

Now, what did Sahitya Akademi do with the novel "Gulo"?

Works published between 2016-2020 were considered for Sahitya Akademi awards in 2022. Meaning Gulo was out of the race.

Meaning, the one who wrote the revolutionary preface of Gulo got the Sahitya Akademi translation award, and Gulo was out of the race.

So was Gulo's preface blackmailing? Understand it as such.

There is much more cannon fodder in Gulo's preface.

'Desil bayna sab jan miththa' (Native speech is sweet to all), this is recited by the mainstream, and Kedar Kanan also recites it. But Avahattha was a literary language.

But Jyotirishwar-pre Vidyapati is different from the Vidyapati of Sanskrit and Avahattha. Possibly the son of Shri Mahesh Thakur of the barber caste from Bisfi village. In the parallel tradition of Bidapat Nach, dance-drama of Vidyapati Padavali (pre-Jyotirishwar) is performed. The description of pre-Jyotirishwar Vidyapati is found in the book "Ishvara Pratyabhijna-Vibharshini" written by Abhinavagupta of Kashmir (late 10th and early 11th century), where he mentions Vidyapati. In Sridhar Das's Sadukti Karnamrit (composed 11 February 1206, see Madhyakaleen Mithila, Vijay Kumar Thakur) – Sridhar Das has quoted five verses of Vidyapati here, which are in the language of Vidyapati Padavali. "Jāva na mālato kara paragāsa tāve na tāhi madhukara vilāsa." and "Mundala mukula kataya makaranda". Jyotirishwar (1275-1350) mentions Bidapat in Shashthah Kallol – "Atha Vidyavant Varnana" and Ashtamah Kallol – "Atha Rajya Varnana". So Vidyapati must have become so famous that Jyotirishwar mentioned him in the context of dance. (Picture of Vidyapati by Panakalal Mandal, awarded the Videha Chitrakala Samman).

After that, Kedar Kanan writes the summary of the novel Gulo. It seems he either did not read the novel properly or could not understand its meaning. He writes – "Anwar understood that the old woman (Sukhba's mother) had money. His efforts were not futile... he would take it by force." and whatnot.

But this is not in the novel; neither Anwar nor any other character does what Kedar Kanan suggests. Those who are about to flee give money when everyone thinks they will not give. Those with wings replace the fan and give it when even Gulo suspects they will not replace. Anwar helped many times, later also warned that vultures are hovering for money. Yes, sometimes when money was not available/delayed, he was definitely annoyed.

Kedar Kanan is surprised by the language of Gulo; the mainstream should be too. But that only shows his distance from Maithili literature for 15 years.

Kedar Kanan is surprised by many other things; on a situation after a quarrel in the novel, he writes that "in the so-called cultured society, such an incident would be taken lightly, but in ordinary people's houses, such an incident..." etc.

Kedar Kanan's pretence of being surprised creates humour; we see this as the arrogance of the mainstream. It seems he has come from another planet and lives in a big palace in Supaul, far from the common world.

This 9-page preface disrupts the reading of Gulo. So I urge you to start reading Gulo directly from page 17. Read the novel in one sitting. Then come back and read this preface or cannon fodder as a humorous essay. In the Hindi translation of Gulo, Kedar Kanan's preface "The Story of the Last Destitute Person" is placed at the end of the novel, and for that, Gaurinath is a person to be thanked. □

Gulo (Original Maithili)

In Gulo, only the grihastha (householder) and malik (master) are mentioned, who have a pen-orchard, but it is just mentioned, and once there is an address saying Bhabhana, meaning he is a Brahmin.

Only after Gulo's death does Doctor Malik come, who while crying says that now what will they call him, Malik? Understand that he is a Kayastha, but in this novel, his caste is not described. So a grihastha/malik appears two or three times, and the doctor saheb once.

And the one who gets the most money is the owner of Palai Mill – Dashrath Mandal.

This novel is roughly divided into 14 sections, and with flashbacks, it presents the life of Gulo Mandal along with the description of his surroundings. The purpose of the novel is not to give a detailed description of time and place, and therefore it does not analyze the inherent problems of society or the economy. It

revolves around Gulo Mandal. Wherever Gulo Mandal's eyes, his virtual or real presence go, the novel wanders there. If it goes here and there for a while, it returns. Even after his death, when people are angling for their share in the relief fund, the writer returns to Riniya, and she hears Gulo's call, listening for another call from her father. "He is crying." And the novel ends – "Father has gone. Riniya is crying."

This book demands analysis in terms of textuality of words and sentences, distinct from ordinary novels. Julia Kristeva's longitudinal relation pole connecting writer and reader, and the vertical pole connecting this text with another text.

Gulo is not divided into chapters; it flows like a stream, but through the use of typography in the print version, chapters or sections have been made possible for the convenience of the reader. However, often within a section, by giving paragraph-spaces, sub-sections are also created.

Now let's read Gulo once.

First Section of Gulo

The text begins with Tila Sakaranti, not Makar Sankranti! (This is for the translator.)

Riniya (Gulo's youngest daughter) is plastering the courtyard, singing a song. Do you see any inferiority complex or prejudice in Gulo's family? Take a cinematic experience, think, imagine, plastering while singing, then dew like water droplets, the westerly wind, severe cold, Riniya is wearing only a salwar and a farak, and the mother's call – "This girl doesn't let me live. Go, wrap the sheet around you." And stage this scene. But while plastering, the sheet will get soiled, after it gets soiled, then it will be fine (This is for the translator).

And now think, this is Gulo Mandal's house, not of Gulo Kanan of the so-called cultured society.

In the so-called cultured society too, mornings are like this, Tila Sakaranti is played like this, plastering is done like this, and the mother screams like this – "This girl doesn't let me live. Go, wrap the sheet around you."

You will also find the morning routines of Gulo's family here.

Second Section of Gulo

"Do you recognize me? If you don't recognize me, then recognize me. I am Gulo Mandal. My house is on this square. If you have messed with me, then understand. I am Gulo Mandal."

Flashback in one paragraph, Gulo's father Munilal, Gulo's two younger sisters, the death of his mother, leaving the railway job, Benarji Saheb, the head officer at Saharsa railway, did not like that Munilal left his job; he would have given him big, live fish? After three children, the request for Munilal's elder brother's daughter was withdrawn, Munilal brought everyone to him. The grandson was sharp and clever (Mahender).. got Basdih written. Gulo fled and came to Kosi Chowk, Sipaul. Settled on government land of Bihar.

While at the railway, Munilal had made a lot of iron and wooden tools. Small and big khurpi, kodari, khandi, dabi, kudhari, bhala, barhchi. All these are still there in Gulo's house. This is his inheritance. Nothing else left by his ancestors.

Then Riniya's restlessness. She had received five hundred rupees at school, clothing allowance. Didiji said – 'Buy shoes.' But it got spent on Gulo's other urgency; Riniya says.. they all got wasted.

Third Section of Gulo

Conflict between Chhotua (Gulo's youngest son) and Riniya's perspective towards work.

Fourth Section of Gulo

A month ago, Gulo's eldest son Arjunma went to Panijab (Punjab – a note for the translator). Kandahawali (Arjunma's wife) and Sujit (Arjunma's son).

Riniya has a craving, so she keeps spitting.

Fish was made on New Year's day, because New Year has become a festival day for everyone. That day, Riniya had carried the fish. Actually, Riniya insisted on eating meat.

Anwar sits in a bamboo frame next to Gulo. He administers injections. He charges ten rupees for one injection.

Gulo's in-laws are in Bela, and his wife's name is Belawali.

Earlier, Gulo had collapsed while smoking gājā (cannabis). Meaning, the trade of the intoxicant gājā used to happen all around. Since Bela, his sister-in-law had come to see her sister, meaning Gulo's wife, and says – "This gajpiā (cannabis smoker) has ruined my sister."

Kandahawali had searched the upper floor (she had searched, so that they wouldn't bring it – note for translator).

The process of sending invitations for the sister's marriage, a sari, saya, blouse, and 251 rupees had to be given. He goes to Sonak, with Chhotua and Riniya. Gulo's eldest daughter Runiya has also come directly from her in-laws, wants to take her sister Riniya to her in-laws. But she refuses; people say that since the father is sick, days are difficult, so she has come to earn a living. She is very sharp; Gulo is surprised, how did this girl understand all this. The girl is suppressed, but if she refuses, will any prestige remain (will any deed remain, prestige is a small word – note for translator), "Even if I have to get beaten up.."

For Riniya, Sonak is no less than a pilgrimage because she has never even seen a train until now, meaning she has not boarded one, not even seen one, meaning she has only heard about it. So there are two Indias.

Fifth Section of Gulo

Smoke and fumes. "Anwar gives no answer. He had helped many times before, given money, given medicine, given injections. ... Gulo does not mention returning."

Sixth Section of Gulo

Rajindar Dealer and his co-brother Inra Ganhi. Inra Ganhi's eldest son Doma runs a grocery shop. The second son has a water shop, keeps all kinds of chargers, and charges five rupees to charge one mobile phone. Many in Punarwas have no electricity. The third son does mobile recharge, downloads films and songs. Does photo editing. Takes photos. The fourth son Barjesh runs a medicine shop. He says – 'The only difference between any doctor and me is that the doctor has a degree and I don't.'

Seventh Section of Gulo

Kandahawali has found a new employment making makhana in the makhana fields of Malhad.

Sukhba threw his mother out of the house. She is Inra Ganhi's father's mother-in-law.

Sukhba brought his mother home.

Eighth Section of Gulo

Sowing mung beans, hiring a plough, asks for two and a half hundred for providing plough, support, and chauki.

It needs to be fixed tomorrow.

"There is an M.P. election. Congress has fielded Ranjita Ranjan." Nareshba gives Gulo one thousand rupees from Ranjita Ranjan; Gulo has six votes at home. But Nareshba got wiped out. But Fulba Modi wins, but Gulo does not go to the meeting "You got a fat car (Fulba). You do (the meeting)."

Then a quarrel at home; Kandahawali made a necklace and put it around her neck. After locking the wheat drum, she went to her maternal home.

Ninth Section of Gulo

Two of Gulo's houses collapsed.

Baba said, they have painted the house with plaster. He gave a talisman, but it didn't work.

Worship of Kalibandi, bhagait, phulhasi. Now they don't even apply kush ka lep.

Tenth Section of Gulo

Chhotua works as a labourer for the landlord Dashrath Mandal there. To get it fixed tomorrow, he asks for 1200 rupees advance, gets 1000. But instead of getting it fixed tomorrow, he buys a bicycle because Arjunma had sold the bicycle he bought with his own money. He has to see it.

Anwar gave an injection to bring down Riniya's fever.

Tenth Section of Gulo

Gulo has received two betel nuts and two invitations – one for the wedding of Lalo Pandit's granddaughter, the other for the wedding of Sari's daughter-in-law (?).

Eleventh Section of Gulo

Gulo asks the landlord for a torch; if he doesn't give, then neither a single mango nor a luchchi (a kind of bread) will be offered for enjoyment.

Bamboo is not available for less than one and a half hundred; if Gulo sells stolen ones, he would have to give them for one hundred. He got money for five bamboo sticks; for one hundred, Riniya bought a goat. The goat recognized Riniya within a moment.

The landlord did not give the torch; he bought it by adding fifty rupees himself.

He stole luchchi and sisohi from the thief's mango tree. There is a Thakurba who is a serial thief.

Riniya, Jhuniya, and Barseserwali are stealing luchchi.

'Did you get caught?' – Riniya asked.

'Would that Bhabhana catch me?' (Barseserwali)

Gulo's eldest daughter Runiya is married without ceremony. A call comes on Anwar's mobile. Gulo goes there, Chhotua also goes with him. Riniya becomes like a messenger for the luchchi.

Riniya gave the first plucking of mung beans to Satalraena, who gave her twenty rupees.

Runiya's husband's brother Nerhu came; he kept silently looking at Riniya and smiling.

Dashrath Mandal's brother-in-law's son is in Nepal; there is talk for Riniya. But Gulo asks for a four-month time; Arjunma is useless, but still he asks him.

Twelfth Section of Gulo

A call comes on Anwar's mobile from Arjunma; he is crying.

Gulo has a cough; the deal to buy two katha of thokda (land) for two hundred rupees was made. How much dust has gone into his lungs. He drove a peg; the ten-rupee fan broke, but he replaced the worn-out one.

Thirteenth Section of Gulo

Once, Riniya had brought Gachhpakku mangoes, and the landlord gave fifty rupees. The landlord's wife had them and ate.

Belawali's fever is not subsiding. Which girl, which woman brought some mangoes?

Gulo kept fidgeting all night. Breathlessness and cough.

"The old woman has a fever. She (Gulo) doesn't feel like getting up... The girl is restless, sometimes at home, sometimes running to the orchard. The boy sleeps until eight o'clock."

Last Section of Gulo

Gulo has cut and kept seven or eight pegs of the sky... now he doesn't feel like doing anything.

Riniya's goat is not eating or drinking. Who knows what has happened to it.

Another time, Gulo would tend the orchard even at night. This time he didn't get to. Now there is no caretaker there...

...Kandahawali arrived. – 'Papa, the mason from yesterday will come tomorrow. He will fix it.'

Gulo said – 'Girl, that will cost a thousand rupees. I don't have a single rupee in hand.'

'He will come. Whatever it costs, we will pay.'

Arjun returned from Panijab.

The nephew Mahender, who had deceitfully taken Gulo's house deed from Gulo's father, heard from a friend that his uncle was sick and came to visit. Gulo spoke ill of him.

Mahender performed the worship of Satlarayan Bhagwan. Riniya went there; her sister-in-law detained her for the night. Riniya learned that Gulo was very upset. She returned in the morning.

The grand finale of this novel... see the art..

Mother asked if she had performed the Ratuka worship. Riniya's mind was not in hearing about the events. The mother said – 'Mother, I don't have money. I will bring medicine for Father.'

...

Riniya grabbed his ear and shook it – 'Father!'

Nothing. Absolutely nothing.

'Mother, run. Go see what happened to Father! Father! Hey Father! Father, hey Father!'

...

'The buffalo has flown away.' (a saying meaning the situation is hopeless)

Then due to lack of money, no wood, and due to lack of wood, Gulo is buried.

"... there is an earthquake!" Parameshwar shouted.

...

The earthquake came again.

While giving the pyre, two people came on motorcycles, Kanhaiya and Jagdish.

Then the dead Gulo goes to the hospital, his post-mortem is done; there was already a commotion in the hospital about Gulo dying in the earthquake, so the document was prepared.

Then Gulo was brought back to the crematorium. Chhotua gave the pyre, both Kodarwaha (men of Kodarwa caste) buried Gulo with soil.

Some men and people who were Muslims, as they were giving fire and seeing the burial, said – Is this a Hindu or Muslim? ... What is the religion of these Hindus! ... What does religion do? If there is money, children will survive....

The competition among leaders/ministers to give relief after the earthquake. When a natural disaster occurs, there is a competition among them to give relief to the dead to be in the news; the writer wants to show this here.

The W.A.D. Commissioner gave one hundred and fifty rupees...

The M.P. .. five thousand rupees..

The Minister... ten thousand..

Government man.. a check of four lakh..

And then the fight for that money..

Jagdish wants one lakh from it. But the writer turns to Riniya.

"Riniya is sad. She remembers her father. ... Gone! How clear his voice was. .. She felt him calling – Father! Hey Father!.." □

Ramta Jogi (The Wandering Ascetic)

Travelogue, in diary form. The writer writes – "[05.03.2019] The travel literature written so far in Maithili is mostly dull and lifeless. It is a repository of unnecessary details and insignificant information. It has more chronicle-like quality and less narrative quality. This account, written in diary style, does not have a detailed exploration of history and archaeology. It has interesting human anecdotes that illuminate the lifestyle and culture of different countries."

The writer is impressed by Australia – 'Australia is a developed, prosperous, clean, pure, with good air and an advanced standard of living country... Due to the absence of poverty, illiteracy, and social discrimination, there is a lot of peace in life there.'

It reminds me of a friend who went to Darbhanga for an exam, roamed around the university area, and returned, saying that there is no city better than Darbhanga in all of Bihar. Although the writer says that his travelogue does not have a detailed exploration of history and archaeology, but in light of the above paragraph, I want to draw attention to the fact that when Britain let go of the American colonies in 1778, Virginia was no longer available for sending convicts. So Captain Phillip, with three ships carrying animals, seeds, sheep, and 6 small ships and 1400 men and women, of whom half were convicts, arrived at the coast of present-day Sydney on 26 January 1788, and the original aborigines were gradually pushed inland from all coastal sides. Their waterholes were occupied, and even today, when Australia Day is celebrated on 26 January, the original aborigines mourn the day; they now live on reservations. But when James Cook went to New Zealand, he treated the native Maori people well.

Now come to Ramta Jogi –

[30.09.2018] He left for Melbourne with his son Kumar Saumya in business class.

He sends photos of his elder son Santosh Kumar upon arrival. His son Kumar Saumya is a C.A., and daughter-in-law Madhulika (Madhu) is a software engineer; the son married within the caste; to show this, the writer uses the following sentence – "The arrangement of Bhata-Adauri is made. Madhulika's mother Jayamala Yadav is from Adauri..."

There is mention of some Indian shops at Sanctuary Lake, and also of Patanjali products. For four months, Saumya had been serving his cancer-stricken mother; after her death, he has now brought his father. Saumya says that in Australia, 'orange' is not called 'mandarin' but 'orange'. Point Cook is the

western part of Melbourne. Indians and Africans live here in large numbers; crime also occurs here (it does occur – the writer does not mention this).

Mention of Swastika Goenka (C.A.) and Anand Goenka (Software Engineer). The Hindi film 'Sui Dhaaga' is released in Australia. At Dosa Hut, all the beautiful Indian girls are waitresses. One's smile was long... the writer thinks – Why did she smile?... Whatever it may be, such a fluid spiritual experience gives some joy for a few moments in a dried-up life.

Good news came from India; the university became ready to pay the arrears of pension. Trains that go long distances are called 'bullet trains' here; accidents do not occur in them. Trams run in the city; there are no trams in Calcutta, but the trams here are good.

He talked to Kedar Kanan's nephew Rahul Vats. He and his wife Ashwini are both engineers and work in Melbourne; they have a daughter, Ayeska. He also talked to Ahmed Nomani of Kishanpur.

He heard two 'habshi' (Abyssinian) women shrieking. 'Negro' and 'habshi' are offensive words, like 'Gidarmara' of Simra in Madhubani, also called 'Banjara', like 'Pathan' is used insultingly for Pashtuns in Pakistan, but in India, people also use Pathan as a title. Later, the writer distances himself from using the word 'habshi'.

The relationship between the mother-in-law and daughter-in-law (not father-in-law and daughter-in-law) is strained. "As soon as so many of the children went abroad, they had already bought that country's currency. If I had done that, I would have felt very bad. Madhu is a bit outspoken."

The Durga Puja of a rock band in Melbourne. – 'There is no place for violence here.' Four years ago, on Mahaashtami, he had gone to Mahishi with Kedar Kanan, Sushmita, Tussi, and Raman Kumar Singh to Taranand Viyogi's place; they visited Mother Tara, offered sacrifice, then went to Karuthan; people offer milk. Viyogi says – Blood flows at Tarathan, and milk flows at Karuthan!

Most of the car drivers are women.

"Office alcohol party, Madhu was in a hangover."

Saumya wants to settle in Australia; it's been three years; when four years are completed, he will apply for citizenship.

"Two women, clinging to each other under a single sheet, were walking on the road. Very likely they are lesbian."

Shashi Kapoor said about his foreign experiences that when he and his friends used to hug and laugh and joke, the people there thought they were gay. The writer would have written correctly.

Saumya wants to settle there, but Madhu is afraid.

The writer talked to Professor Mahendra Jha; the pension for June-July had arrived. He wants, and Kedar, Kamta, Vinay Kumar Jha, Vaidyanath Jha want him to write a lot there. The first part of the novel Madar came in Antika in March 2016, but not later. On 24.10.2018, he started writing a new novel. He hasn't finalized the name yet. Satchidanand Satchu liked the excerpt of 'Madar' very much. He had sent a message.

The paddy in his (Supaul) land for rehabilitation has been harvested; the sharecropper has given his share. He has to store it; if the sharecropper sows something again, he will have to wait a few more months. He was talking to two people; he is also worried that they might cheat him.

Madhu orders three glasses of white wine (country liquor); the taste is like toddy.

Saumya orders a Japanese dish, Sushi (made from stale rice and chicken).

The sea fish Barramundi, but the taste is not like pond fish, chāmp, or river fish. Raman Kumar Singh got some award (the name of the award is not written) for his poetry collection 'Fir Se Hariyar'; he is translating Gulo into Hindi (28.10.2018).

29.10.2018 – He wrote four pages; if he writes this much daily, the novel will be ready in a month (Japanese novelist Haruki Murakami writes 10 Japanese pages daily without fail – roughly 1600 words).

Here, the city council is called Windham. African greeting – fist bump. With a Myki card, you can travel on metro, bus, and tram. A strange name for a station – Aircraft.

A beggar boarded the compartment; Saumya felt she might be asking for drugs. Later he saw her downstairs; she came with a cigarette in her mouth, rubbing her chest as if looking for a lighter... a completely erotic gesture...

The writer has to take an Enfo injection once a month to maintain normal hemoglobin levels.

Today is a holiday. Vikas, Priyanka, Abhishek, Nidhi, and Ashwini... Vikas and Ashwini's jobs are at risk. A call came from Nidhi's mother from Tata.

Shop for boats... a woman is busy with the shop's accounts. She stared... realized that we had been watching her from before. ... She looked at us. We looked at her. I felt scared. What happened to her?

If you call an African 'habshi' or 'black', they get angry. All Africans are dark and tall. Very few have a good physique. By coincidence, the African girl present in the restaurant was beautiful.

Saumya's friend Jaswant Singh, married to a Christian, Angelina. No conversion; he performs yajna and also prays in church.

Saumya and Madhu participate in snorkeling... scuba... Both participate. Viewing the reef, there is glass in the boat's bottom.

Jess Teah and Becky Baldock... they are hugging each other. Jess Teah initiates it. There is a magnetic wave in Becky's embrace.

At Frog's restaurant, you can eat crocodile meat. You can buy kangaroo skin. You can hear Australian aborigines playing the ancient Didgeridoo instrument.

Here you have to pump petrol yourself.

Today I am eating pork for the first time.

Penguin parade...

In the morning, I saw Kedar's message. D.M. Saheb wants to talk... He was just curious about how things were in Melbourne. I also felt relieved.

Saw two girls tightly holding each other, kissing and making out. Looks like they are lesbians. Homosexuality is legal in Australia. Gays can marry gays, and lesbians can marry lesbians.

Ankur came. He used to study with Madhu.

Two women boarded the compartment. Madhu explained that they are revellers. They roam around with needles in their hands, intoxicated.

A chubby, hairy koala is sitting on a support, lazing... Lazy creature.

Kangaroo... wallaby

Emu bird.. white pelican.. lyrebird.. Tasmanian devils (endangered).

From Australia to Kuala Lumpur, then to Ho Chi Minh City. In a city with a population of one crore, 70 lakh are on two-wheelers.

South Vietnam, Mekong River. For the first time, I saw a paddy cutting machine. In Vietnam, they eat snakes, chickens... It is believed there that dog meat increases virility.

Mahaprakash is being greatly missed in Vietnam..

City tour, Chinese pagoda; those who have no children buy a bird and set it free. Madhu buys a bird and sets it free.

From Ho Chi Minh City to Hanoi, North Vietnam. There the river is the Red River.

Madhu's friend Ruchi and her husband Gaurav met there.

The notebook for the travelogue is lost, then found.

Ruchi is a Brahmin, daughter of an I.A.S. officer; Gaurav is a Rajput. They had a love marriage. Ruchi's father strongly opposed the marriage.

Puppet show, sometimes a cat, sometimes a monkey.

There is a farewell hug with Ruchi.

Cambodia Angkor Wat is a mix of Hindu and Buddhist religions. Bhai Yogendra Pathak Viyogi has done a very detailed exploration of Angkor Wat.

Pub Street intersection... a thirty-five-year-old man.. Want girl, sir? Thirty dollars for one hour. Sixty dollars for one night... No, I don't want. A Spanish woman.. Uno, dos, tres... (one, two, three)

I asked – Dónde vives usted? (Where do you live?)

She said – España (Spain).

..At night, the neon lights are shining.

Bangkok, Suvarnabhumi Airport.. a statue depicting the churning of the ocean in between.. Warnings are written in Hindi.. No Tips. The long walk in Bangkok, Arun Temple.

Pattaya.. emaciated, dilapidated Buddha.. I had never seen such a statue of Buddha. At one a.m., we will reach Mumbai. Samrat will receive. [04.01.2019]

Appendix – Andaman Diary

September 2012 – A relative's child, Sanjay, with his wife, was going to Port Blair; he was called. We from Saharsa, he from Mumbai, would meet at Port Blair airport.

Annadurai is standing with a taxi; he is building a house in Chennai; he fears that Andaman might sink into the sea someday. His driver from Ranchi, Uday, will come later. In Port Blair, there is a locality named 'Ranchi'. In Andaman, the largest number are Bengalis, then Tamils.

North Bay; the photo printed on the fifty-rupee note is of this island's mountains and forests. Here, snorkeling, scuba diving, speedboats are all available. There are coral reefs. On a glass boat (glass on the bottom), you can see marine life while sitting.

Plastic is prohibited in 'Jolly Boy'.

Bartang Jarawa adivasis. My friend Lallan (Vinay Kumar Jha, I.A.S.) strongly insisted that I must see the Jarawas.

Havelock Island. □

Madar (The Dead)

Dedicated to the literature lovers Samrat and Neha, this book is based on how the man-woman relationship and the protagonist Madan's suspicion turn him into a murderer. Then the novel ends with the possibility that a criminal background relative shelters him, and Madan's exploitation, along with his mental agitation.

Madan's wife Radha runs the house by sewing clothes. Her eldest daughter, Shanichari, was born on Saturday. But she has no idea; if she gives the blouse she stitched for Gamhariyawali, she would get twenty rupees and could buy rice and spices. If she goes herself and Madan sees her, he will scold her; he does not let Radha go anywhere. The bug of suspicion keeps buzzing in his head.

But it wasn't like this before; Madan would brag that Radha's soap and oil were used up. Her father, Kamesar Azad, was an Intermediate pass of his time. He was a proud father, a tenant farmer of fifty or sixty bighas. But after the death of Kamesar's father, there was division, and Kamesar got five bighas of land, two sons, two daughters, and his own two lives. He was very interested in social work and treating the sick. Both sons somehow got B.A. degrees. Madan ran away to Bombay; there he remembered Radha. After much hardship there, he returned; Radha had gone to her maternal home. He went to his in-laws'; Radha had gone to see a movie, with his elder brother's wife, and from then on, suspicion began.

Kamesar got Radha's second marriage ceremony performed. Shanichari was born, Karamu was born. But Madan's suspicion did not decrease; guarding and beating started.

Madan and Kishor, both brothers, separated. In the field, a glass tree dried up due to obstruction; he had it valued, but Kishor obstructed; he got angry. Then it was sold.

Madan and Kamala had a fight; Madan cut her ear and threw it. Kamala filed a case; Kamesar gave 2-3 hundred rupees to the police to calm it down. The father-in-law got Madan a tempo; he started running it from Pipra to Supaul and Supaul to Pipra. Kamesar got Radha's second marriage performed and brought her back, but his mother insulted her – "Tolerate her, or else I'll cut off her nose." Then beating continued, and Radha would go to her maternal home at Tintoliya. Radha was pregnant.

After passing matric, Radha had enrolled in Intermediate. She needs to fill out the exam form. Her friend has come from her in-laws for this. The college is in Raghupur. Radha is filling the form...

There was a time when ... Madan would strip her naked. .. There is no other joy in life beyond this. But not anymore. Now it hurts. Radha feels like running away somewhere. Eloping with someone. Ashok.. she sees affection for her in his eyes... Radha remembers Shanichari. Remembers Karamu. What would happen to the young child?

Radha remembers some boys who liked her... they would break ber, break jalebi, give mangoes, give jamun... never touched her body... The one from Karjain... like her brother... He is sweet-tongued. Once in winter, he brought a very nice cap from Nepal.

The Intermediate results came out. Radha got a first division in Intermediate (meaning she had also gotten a first division in matric). Radha's in-laws are in Pathra, a little away from Mahavir's house. Two girls from Pathra had taken the Intermediate exam. But none got a first division. Mahavir got a first division; he applied for a mastership at the primary school in Pathra Panchayat. The Mukhiya said he would need to spend some money with the Hakim; if it costs 4-5 thousand, he would get 1500 as honorarium, and in 3-4 months, the money would be recovered. He had come to Tintoliya to see his sister off. Mahavir told

him that if he applied, Radha would get a mastership at Pathra school. His father-in-law had sent a message. Radha also wanted it.

Radha had given birth to a daughter just after the Intermediate exams ended.

Radha started looking for a job. Now Madan had forgotten about beating and abusing. Mahavir got a job at that school. Rekha also came there; she was Radha's younger sister; her in-laws were also in Pathra.

But the hunt for the honorarium's bribe made Madan guard Radha again. ... There was a Raghunath Sahni. He would say while roaming – 'No trust in women!...' Raghunath was completely confused. Madan is not confused. ... He made her quit the job. Radha stayed home. Madan went to his maternal uncle's for help, but got only 100 rupees. The master's honorarium increased to four thousand. Radha started regretting more. If she could get a job again, Mahavir said he would need to meet the headmaster and the Mukhiya; the headmaster said he would need to meet the Mukhiya. Kamesar went to the Mukhiya, but the Mukhiya clearly refused because it had been too long.

Madan suspects Radha's meetings with Mahavir. Kamesar keeps inquiring. What happened, what is the trouble? Why does she whisper with her father-in-law? Madan asks. Radha feels hurt.

Madan went to his sister's. His brother-in-law Rajkumar studies at Intermediate College. He doesn't get his salary. But tuition classes are very popular. The brother-in-law asked – 'Why did you make the girl quit her job? ... You people are suspicious.'

Madan left. He reached home.. Radha had poured kerosene and set herself on fire. Kamesar took care of Radha... there must be something going on between them.

When Madan would go to his sister's, Radha would grumble – 'He doesn't even leave his father-in-law... set fire...'

.. Kamesar takes the girl... buys tonic for Radha. Her father worries so much about these two things... Madan kept thinking. His suspicion was getting confirmed.

Radha says – 'The Didi from Piprahi hasn't come to give rice yet.'

The Didi gave five kilos of rice... Madan got angry. Keep your rice...

This woman is the only one. She called an old husband to sleep with... seeing the medicine in her father's hand, Shanichari got scared – 'Don't kill Mother, Papa.'.. Radha's throat was slit.

Madan left. Madan's maternal uncle's in-laws are in Rampur. The middle sister's husband there is the chief of criminals. He went to the elder sister's husband; the elder sister's daughter got scared. The middle one was there. He said – 'We will keep him. He fell asleep sometime...' Radha came again. Wearing a white sheet. A stake wrapped around her neck.

He woke up. Radha is nowhere. But he feels Radha is standing in front of him. □

Bhot (Vote)

In Bhot, a call comes to the writer/protagonist from his nephew (it is revealed later that he is the protagonist's nephew) Yaduvansh, who came to a village assembly once a long time ago (this is also mentioned later), whom people call Vidhayakji. The protagonist Subhash Ji is counted among the good people, so he seeks his help. He reaches Kariho. Rajindar, a leader of RJD, says that if everyone has a cup of tea here, the boat will cross.

In the assembly election, there is an alliance of RJD, JDU, and Congress. Yaduvansh Kumar Yadav is a candidate from the Pipra Legislative Assembly, which fell to RJD. Kariho used to be in Supaul earlier. This time, through a

trick, they fielded him in the Pipra Assembly; Vijender Yadav used to win from here, so here there are more voters from JDU. Rajindar Yadav ran for Mukhiya from here. He couldn't win, but he's a capable man; he has a name in a non-government college; he goes to college for two or four days a month, marks his attendance, and leaves. Whenever there is a grant, he gets some income. He goes around acting like a big man. The protagonist also goes around with him. When a programme is made in Hardi, the protagonist would go with Kamta (JDU), but neither Dina Pathak (JDU) nor any Congressman knows anything. The protagonist tells Kamta that thinking this way will weaken the RJD-JDU-Congress alliance. Kamta agrees to go to Hardi. Then from Harda to Kariho. This is the protagonist's first experience of election campaigning. Yaduvansh says there is no money. This worries the protagonist. How to fight an election without money? How much could the protagonist donate, 5-10 thousand? Better to spend that much on campaigning; what expense is there in tea and water? He thinks he will bear the campaign expenses, but then he thinks, who knows how much it will cost. The protagonist and Kamta studied in Supaul, and Yaduvansh in Rafiganj; the protagonist tells a story about this: the protagonist and Yaduvansh had gone together on Kamta's bicycle; the bicycle got stolen; Kamta blames Yaduvansh; now Yaduvansh is becoming an MLA from that area; they need each other. But party differences create distance; the top leaders have compromised, but how can years of bitterness evaporate like steam? Bindu Lal Das is a joker. He tells a story: the tea shop owner's name is Bidiya; the bribe he took turned into a cooking pot. Then he started selling tea. Everyone laughed heartily; Bidiya hasn't passed middle school. The protagonist asks Bidiya who he will vote for, but he gives a crooked answer – 'Who I will give and who I won't, why should I tell you?' BJP's candidate is Vishwamohan; he was an MP once, lost the second time, this time his daughter Sujata is the candidate. Vishwamohan is of the Kiyat caste. Once Dilesar Kamat won; he was also Kiyat. Actually, the Socialist Party's leader Vinayak Yadav's son-in-law, Deenbandhu Yadav, also won once. In Pipra, the population of Kiyat is high. Next are Dhanuk, then Jadav. The Dhanuk community has no candidate of their own, so their vote is divided; if Choudhary is a Baniya, and BJP is a Baniya party, where would they go? Yes, if someone is tempted with money... The Samajwadi Party candidate is Satyanarayan Gupta; he is a Teli; most Teli votes will go to him. There's no talk of the Left's candidate, Nagesar Yadav. Muslims are angry with BJP; they will vote for the Grand Alliance. Similarly, Brahmins are angry with the Grand Alliance. Sukhdev is in BJP; actually, people are unhappy with his candidate. Shivji has a tea shop; he doesn't make good tea; he stays intoxicated; he abuses even the Prime Minister; he tells the

protagonist to spend – 'What do you lack?' His daughter Laxmi wears jeans and a top. She has become an expert at making litti tea and harvesting wheat. Shivji tests the protagonist with Laxmi's education; the protagonist asks what 'pushpa' means. Answer – Flower. Shivji, your daughter is sharp at studying! The protagonist has told everyone about his relationship with the candidate; the news spreads; he will come again in ten days. His wife says – 'Wandering around here and there, what's the point? Will people vote because you say so? They might vote. The difference of a hundred or fifty votes matters. Then it would benefit Yaduvansh. What will Yaduvansh give you? If you do your work, you might get some money. Does campaigning fill the stomach? Not everything is about money. If there's no money, then don't go. Just sit here... Today if I don't give you work, will he give me work tomorrow? Do whatever you want – the wife, exasperated, says.

Yaduvansh filed his nomination. Prabhas is the in-charge. The election is approaching; the protagonist reaches Kariho. Kamta has gone to campaign for a minister; he is the candidate of his party, JDU; the constituency has changed, but the party hasn't. Bindu is doing mastership. Private. ... fifty rupees a month. ... Some pay, some don't. ... Whatever he finds, he takes. Some give rice, some give milk, some give fuel... He was once a member of the Panchayat Samiti. By telling the Mukhiya, some public work... for some, Indira Awas... After the work is done... some give ten, some twenty... But in the next election, due to caste polarisation, he lost.

Mannu.. does pāikāri (brokering) of goods and supplies. He has just arranged the expenses... Mannu, brother, I don't think he understands us. Brother Mannu, earlier elections used to be so smooth and peaceful. ... Now it's a free-for-all for self-interest.

Today, everyone's target is the Mushari and Domrahi settlements. In Kariho, there are two dense colonies of Musahars. .. Domrahi are also nearby... Go to every voter's door... He also came to me. He also asked me. The two colonies of Kariho and the Musahari of Bagahio have been covered... Evening has fallen... Chandeshwari took money for tea and water from us; he also took a hundred rupees for a leader of the Musahari... The appeal that Nitish Kumar has made to the voters, the manifesto with 'Saat Nischay', a sample ballot paper, and a calendar – we set out with these... Brother has brought a whole fleet of

vehicles... We are softening our dough... Explain properly to the women. Tell them that Nitish and Lalu have united. Both have become one. This time, there will be no arrow mark here. There will be a lantern... This time, if you give to the lantern, then Nitish will win. She asked – Will Nitish become Chief Minister? He has done a lot for women. The people are staunch supporters of Nitish.

'Has Safina come!' – Jamil is telling. Safina has melted the pride of many. Then a story about Safina. ... She stood in the Mukhiya election. People recognized her. Chandeshwari was a devotee of Safina; he enjoyed going around with her. Will he vote for her! Chandeshwari thinks... Does one vote for work? Safina is not very educated; she has Fokanian (10th?) pass...

Vishwamohan's house is at Kataiya. There, one gets 100 rupees. Sanjay and Jayprakash are both BJP supporters. Daily news in the newspaper... vehicles carrying cash and alcohol bottles are caught. Gagana – liquor and meat are flowing. BJP will win.

Sipaul.. Rahul Gandhi's speech is there. The entire Gandhi Maidan was packed... He said Modi is a thief... he incites riots, pits Hindus and Muslims against each other... The Grand Alliance will win. Samajwadi Party.. Satyanarayan Sah.. Kamta is upset.. vote-cutter.. Kamta also scolded Vishwamohan.. JDU.. then RJD.. sometimes BJP, sometimes Bengal stamp.. Nitish has done a great deal for women, 33 out of 100 seats, he gave bicycles.

There is a colony of readers.. he distributed leaflets. Not lantern, lotus. We – lantern. He – lotus. Lotus.

What Modi said. Things that defamed Lalu. Kidnapping, rape, and murder.. As evening falls, people lock themselves inside.. People imitate Modi and Lalu.

If BJP wins, they will abolish reservation.. This discussion, Mohan Bhagwat said... Meaning.. against Mandal, Kamandal...

The MLC Haroon Rashid – what is the population of Brahmins? Two or two and a half percent? And in jobs... they have everything!

Chandeshwari.. Safina has become very fair.. All parties take money, then give tickets. She got late. By then, the ticket was sold.. Chandeshwari.. started staring at Safina's every limb.. BJP wants to drive away Muslims. Muslims are scared – Safina said.. Just as Hitler killed the Jews, similarly Modi will destroy Muslims.. In this country, vultures are circling.

BJP is spending heavily now.. Jamil.. Modi is a first-class liar! Ramdhan is gossiping.

Today Prabhas came. Seven thousand rupees for booth expenses were given. There are two booths.

The Ram temple, BJP will build it.. Will those who elected them build the temple?.. We will vote for Modi.. blind devotee..

Suryanarayan Communist.. Nitish is double-faced.. one mouth for BJP.. the other for RJD.

Kamal Das is a BJP supporter. .. 56-inch chest.. Pakistan is still lingering in India!... It will get caught by China.. Everyone laughs at Ramdev's talk.

To get votes, Modi can even attack Pakistan. .. Will BJP fight? Won't they fight for Hindus?.. Muslims should be sent to Pakistan. Lal Pathak made a provocative statement.. Nationalist Lal, you got burned! Now what's missing is a humanist. Deena Pathak.. Modi hasn't been accused of corruption.. Modi is a great corrupt. Sudhir coffee – Kamta's liberalism completely changed the atmosphere.

The campaign has ended.. Peaceful.. Everything is echoing like a whirlpool.

People started lining up an hour earlier. A woman voter was showing her inked finger, polling was low in Sipaul bazaar. This news worried the BJP supporters. In the city, lotus voters are more.

Safina has come to cast her vote. .. 'Why did you come?' Chandeshwari went out saying this. Safina smiled. In the morning, Chandeshwari went to Navtol. There was talk of the election with Safina... BJP says we will win. The Grand Alliance says we will win. Whatever happens now. Safina will go to Delhi in two or three days. Chandeshwari asked – 'When will you come?' Safina said – 'BJP creates new scandals every day..' Chandeshwari – 'Will life go on like this?' Safina was silent.. It is better to die fighting... It is death, not life. □

Rereading of Ghardekhiya, Rajkamal Monograph (Nit Naval Rajkamal), Banait Bigadait, Gulo, Ramta Jogi, Madar and Bhot

From the samples of Ghardekhiya, Rajkamal Monograph (Nit Naval Rajkamal), Banait Bigadait, Gulo, Ramta Jogi, and Bhot given above, Subhash Chandra Yadav's style, use of metaphor and symbol, the ever-changing centre of the narrative, visual and phonetic imagery must have become clear to you. Like the sage of Selahes, folk deities enter the writer, and he starts touching, brings everything out with his digging stick, starts documenting.

So Subhash Chandra Yadav's style is the Sage's style.

But in the glory of Ghardekhiya (written in 1975), Sukhdev used to cheat many people in the election. That became the novel Bhot in 2022. Some difference certainly came between 1975 and 2022, as the protagonist says in Bhot (2022) – 'Brother Mannu, earlier elections used to be so smooth and peaceful... Now it's a free-for-all for self-interest.' But in 1975 too, he says – 'How does Sukhdev, being a vote-cutter, earn so much? He used to cheat many people in the election.' The incident in Dhundhame Ghatna (written in 1971) of Ghardekhiya, which reminded one of 'Waiting for Godot' (Samuel Beckett), could become a postmodern novel. Following the style of his Ghardekhiya, Jagdish Prasad Mandal wrote his own Ghardekhiya in his own style. That text established a dialogue with another writer, who is his equal in age (one year older), but started writing thirty years later.

So his text dialogues with its own text in time and space, and also with another writer's text.

Subhashchandra Yadav's Ghardekhiya –

"The boy had come from Calcutta to the village in the rainy season; now as soon as he sends a telegram, the expenses for the wedding will be taken care of. He will come ten days before the auspicious date; whoever he has to see, he will see."

See this excerpt from Jagdish Prasad Mandal's Ghardekhiya –

"He brought two pairs of dhotis from the courtyard and placed them in front. Seeing the dhotis, Doman said – 'Samaiḍh, no matter how poor you are, you have preserved your honor. How can you wear a dhoti at your daughter's doorstep?' Luchia, who was given a piece of sack, kept watching. Hearing Doman's words, she said in a low voice – 'Tell Samaiḍh that when the daughter comes, then it will be her house, only then it's ours. We are giving.' Laughing loudly, Doman said – 'When our daughter comes to this house, then will she be your Samadhīn, or is it now?'"

Just as Riniya brings Amāthi, Karachi, Patalo wherever she finds them, Subhash collects facts from all sides and creates a narrative, a grand narrative. So the hero of Gulo is not Gulo but Riniya; it begins with Riniya, ends with Riniya. And Riniya created this space herself; the writer had assigned her the role of a co-artist, but with her dedication, she forced the writer to make her the heroine. The conflict between Gulo's daughter and Gulo's youngest son regarding their perspective towards household work. "The girl is restless, sometimes at home, sometimes running to the orchard. The boy sleeps until eight o'clock."

But then when Gulo sells stolen bamboo for 500 rupees, Riniya buys a goat with that money. The writer does not write that this is exactly those 500 rupees,

but by Gulo giving that money to Riniya so easily, Riniya's self-confidence is evident.

Gulo's father left him small and large khurpi, kodari, khandi, dabi, kudhari, bhala, barhchi. Smoke and fumes, deceit, and Gulo had to settle on government land.

The greatest sorrow of Gulo's death was felt by Riniya; the writer keeps Riniya's presence at both the beginning and the end.

Gulo's eldest son's migration to Punjab for employment. The entire market is Rajindar Dealer's co-brother Inra Ganhi and his four sons. Then step outside the market: Bela, Bina, and Sonak. And then Gulo receives two betel nuts and two invitations – one for the wedding of Lalo Pandit's granddaughter, the other for the wedding of Sari's daughter-in-law. Gulo's in-laws are in Bela, and his wife's name is Belawali. Earlier, Gulo had collapsed while smoking gājā. Meaning, the trade of the intoxicant gājā used to happen all around. The process of sending invitations for the sister's marriage, a sari, saya, blouse, and 251 rupees had to be given. He goes to Sonak, with Chhotua and Riniya. Gulo's eldest daughter Runiya is married without ceremony. Runiya also comes directly from her husband's place, wants to take her sister Riniya to her in-laws. But she refuses; people say that since the father is sick, days are difficult, so she has come to earn a living. She is very sharp; Gulo is surprised, how did this girl understand all this. And in the end, Riniya learns that Gulo is very upset. She returns in the morning. Mother asked if she had performed the Ratuka worship. Riniya's mind was not in hearing about the events. The mother said – 'Mother, I don't have money. I will bring medicine for Father.'

At his sister's wedding, Gulo goes to Sonak. Wherever Gulo goes, his body language changes. The girl is suppressed, but she scolds and shouts; the wedding will happen, otherwise, there will be a loss of honor.

To show what kinds of employment exist, the novelist takes his daughter-in-law Kandahawali to Malhad, where she finds a new employment making makhana. Chhotua works as a labourer for Dashrath Mandal in the mill. Sowing mung beans, hiring a plough, he asks for two and a half hundred for providing plough,

support, and chauki. Then the beginning of Gulo's death is described like this: Gulo has a cough; the deal to buy two katha of thokda (land) for two hundred rupees was made.

To see family relationships, problems of old age, go to Sukhba; he had thrown his mother out, then brought her back due to bad reputation. She is Inra Ganhi's father's mother-in-law.

To see local culture, worship of Kalibandi, bhagait, phulhasi. Now after that, they don't even apply kush ka lep.

Gulo asks the landlord for a torch; if he doesn't give, then neither a single mango nor a luchchi will be offered for enjoyment. And look no further – Bamboo is not available for less than one and a half hundred; if Gulo sells stolen ones, he would have to give them for one hundred.

And there are thieves too. He stole luchchi and sisohi from the thief's mango tree. There is a Thakurba who is a serial thief. So there is a difference between Gulo's theft of bamboo and the Thakurba's theft. Gulo's main business is a tea shop; stealing bamboo is once or twice a year, but the Thakurba is a serial thief. Riniya, Jhuniya, and Barseserwali are stealing luchchi. 'Would that Bhabhana catch me?' (Barseserwali). All these orchards belong to Bhabhana.

The orchard owner is someone else. In tribal areas, it belongs to the government, and the Forest Act gives tribals the right to collect mahua, forest produce, etc. But in Sipaul, the orchard is not government-owned. So the condition of the proletariat here is worse; the Forest Act does not apply here. So once Riniya had brought Gachhpakku mangoes, and the landlord gave fifty rupees. The landlord's wife had them and ate.

Runiya's husband's brother Nerhu came; he kept silently looking at Riniya and smiling.

Dashrath Mandal's brother-in-law's son is in Nepal; there is talk for Riniya. But Gulo asks for a four-month time; Arjunma is useless, but still he asks him.

Dashrath Mandal has money, but Gulo did not agree immediately; he asks Arjunma. Meaning the institution still exists.

So Riniya is definitely close to Gulo; the daughter-in-law who had left after quarreling is also not completely distant; look here – ...Kandahawali arrived. – 'Papa, the mason from yesterday will come tomorrow. He will fix it. Whatever it costs, we will pay.'

The writer takes you both far and near. The centre is sometimes Gulo, sometimes Riniya, and sometimes Kandahawali.

In Ramta Jogi, Subhash Chandra Yadav experiences some things that many people do elsewhere (leaving India), like vehicles stopping to let people cross a zebra crossing, like in Singapore. If you go to Europe, at a corner with a side road, other vehicles stop when they see you; people here push their vehicle forward, hoping the other person will show kindness coming from behind. The writer smokes a lot; he also realized that there is a rule there that you cannot smoke in a full or partial enclosed space, but not smoking in public places has also become accepted in India now; earlier people used to make smoke rings in offices, and now if you want to smoke hidden in the bathroom, people frown. The protagonist of the Ghardekhiya story collection also smokes a lot; it seems the writer has a long history of smoking, and so his daughter-in-law Madhulika is also worried about this. Then calls kept coming from Supaul; D.M. would talk; he would only feel reassured when asked how he was doing. Meaning that even now, people do not believe that the police-administration are just asking about their well-being.

In 'Ek Dinak Ghar (1973)' of Ghardekhiya, the psychoanalytic method was used; in 'Tirth (1969)' of Ghardekhiya, the storyteller writes about the courtyard of Balbabali. No doctor would tell her... but she tells.

This method was expanded in Madar (2021). !.. Raghunath is a complete talker. Madan is not a talker. ... And feminism – Madan's daughter Radha passing in first division but not being able to assert her rights over her body, stopping Madan, quitting her job, but her murder. And to try to prevent that murder, the writer brings Shanichari forward – 'Don't kill Mother, Papa.' The writer does

not give Madan the benefit of doubt; he declares that Madan is not a talker. But he finds shelter, at his maternal uncle's in-laws; they are dons; the middle sister's husband is the chief of criminals. And he gives him shelter. Why does he give him shelter? The reader understands, so that he can commit crimes too. So the writer creates an atmosphere and leaves the reader to read and reread the story.

And leaving aside Derrida's deconstruction, even the deconstruction of the field has happened here – Madan's father, Kamesar Azad, was an Intermediate pass of his time. He was a proud father, a tenant farmer of fifty or sixty bighas. But after the death of Kamesar's father, there was division, and Kamesar got five bighas of land.

And this happens in language too. Those who speak Thethi/Pachpania (a dialect) will say 'Panjab' and write it too; and Kedar Kanan's so-called elite class, when they speak of dengue, correct it to 'Dengi' using English. Latin and Sanskrit grammar stabilized languages, but in the modern era, Marathi speakers reading Sant Dnyaneshwar's Dnyaneshwari have to take help of commentary.

Derrida's deconstruction considers sound, history, and culture as part of the text along with language.

In Gulo, you feel that there is neither exploiter nor exploited, and this comes from the language; Gulo does not allow even a single luchchi to be enjoyed by the landlord, he also cuts bamboo, etc. But then you recall the atmosphere that Sipaul is not a forest area, and the landlord is a Bhabhana. But Palai Mill belongs to Dashrath Mandal; at the square, the soānsī (business?) is done by a non-Brahmin. Baba said, they have painted the house with plaster. He gave a talisman, but it didn't work. The talisman got spoiled; he also performed a ritual; you think superstition has ended, but then worship of Kalibandi, bhagait, phulhasi. Now they don't even apply kush ka lep. So change has occurred in culture as well, and in economics as well.

When you read 'Kathak Banal Lok' of Ghardekhiya, you feel like you are reading Gulo. The government gives money for house collapse. In Madar, we saw how feminism came to the fore with Radha's first division in Intermediate,

meaning she had it in matric too. You can read the same text in many ways. Gulo Mandal's caste is not mentioned; from the title, you can guess; 'Mandal' was from the Mandal Commission, and in West Bengal, 'Mandal' appears among Dalits. Kedar Kanan had seen Subhash Chandra Yadav Ji at Gulo's tea shop and had read all of Kumar Pawan's 'Paith', but his villagers said that they had seen those stories happening in their village, while we had only read them. In Madar, the writer is even more cautious; Kamesar's father had 50-60 bighas of land; after Madar, Madan went to his maternal uncle's in-laws; they are all dons. So Gulo can have multiple readings, and Madar as well, and this is what Jacques Derrida's deconstruction says. In South India, many priests of tribal societies have become Brahmins; priests come for Kalibandi worship, bhagait, phulhasi; non-Brahmins can also become Brahmins; without fieldwork, how can one know how a non-Brahmin becomes a Gahbar and Bhagat? But at Gram-Rudrapur (Bhaya Tulapatganj, Madhubani district), Brahmin bhagats perform the service of Gahbar. In Mithila, among the Santal community, Murmu Pandits recite verses from texts dating back to the Indus Valley Civilization with rhythm; people of the Santal community will tell you this. This is a way to prove the antiquity and continuity of one's script, history, and civilization. So gradually, the two discourses start a dialogue, and it keeps changing according to place, time, and people, but with no fixed centre. Literature, folk culture, oral tradition, history, and science merge.

After the British left, the people of India started creating new definitions of their history, culture, and its theoretical basis. But since the Rigvedic period, there has been a parallel tradition in India in the form of Nārāśaṁsī and narratives. But in Maithili, a certain mentality wanted to occupy all the space. Due to the burden of their ignorance, they tried to trample that space. But with all of Michel Foucault's disciplinary institutions still existing, that is not possible now, and therefore the internet has its importance. But it has been observed that the presence of women and the deprived on the internet is low in all linguistic spaces; the parallel stream of Maithili worked more on this, and today the results are before everyone. The mainstream, which did not notice the parallel stream, did not engage with it, now wants to be noticed by the parallel stream.

And this comes from democracy, and that is vote-based. Now come to 'Bhot'. It too can have multiple readings. Many kinds of equations can be seen being formed in this novel. No centre is permanent. At the grassroots, everyone is

opposed to each other, but the decision at the top turned out to be something else.

Feminism has now taken a turn; in Madar, Radha passes in first division but is killed from the margins. But Nitish is doing a lot for women. He has fifty percent of the votes, so what. Riniya had received 500 rupees for clothing, which you read about in Gulo. Now in Bhot, there is 33% reservation for women, bicycles for children. And so when the candidate of the Mahagathbandhan (grand alliance) of RJD, Congress, and JDU is fielded, the protagonist says – it is necessary to tell women that if they vote for the lantern, Nitish will become Chief Minister. Even with a lakh flaws in votes and elections, this stirs a new social element every five years, and the deprived classes, including women, experience being powerful. Muslims are angry with B.J.P., Brahmins are angry with the Mahagathbandhan, B.J.P. is a Baniya party, all parties sell tickets – all these discussions happen at the tea shop in Pipra and also in Lutyens' Zone in Delhi. That child labourer's story from the film 'Chillar Party' comes to mind, who says – everyone is taught not to lie, etc., but when they grow up, everyone lies, etc., so what difference did it make whether someone studied or not! □

Gulo: Art and Language

'Gulo: Art and Language' has been edited by the neo-Brahminical Taranand Viyogi and the Brahminical Kedar Kanan, both awarded by Sahitya Akademi and recipients of many assignments.

And so not a single person who writes in Pachpania or Thethi was invited to write an article for this book because they belong to the parallel stream, which is the enemy of both the Brahminical and neo-Brahminical ideologies of the two editors; thus, though they abuse each other, they unite against the parallel stream, and so this book (it will be clarified further) is a book of flattery.

In the 67-page 'Gulo', Kedar Kanan had written a 9-page preface (The Story of the Last Destitute Person); now its burden is on Taranand Viyogi's shoulders in 'Gulo: Art and Language' (a 5-page introduction). According to Subhash Chandra Yadav, Taranand Viyogi's ideology is not stable, but in our opinion, his

ideology is stable, and it is the same as Kedar Kanan's blackmailing. There are many flaws in Brahminical institutions, and they make them vulnerable to blackmail. There is no Brahminical institution that Taranand Viyogi does not abuse every few months, and upon receiving honor, he does not praise them profusely. Examples like Chetna Samiti and Sahitya Akademi are being cited. He writes somewhere – 'Brahmins are the progenitors of Brahminism, but in its thicket are also Pachpaniyas, Dalits. How does it happen that about two hundred Dalit-Pachpaniya people write in Maithili exactly the same thing, in the same gesture, that serves the purpose of Brahminism. You can also see such Dalit people chairing sessions in Brahmin meetings, receiving honors.' And you feel that he is writing this about himself; his language, his literature, his subject matter, his so-called ghazals, his deceit, his greed for awards, his conduct – all are purely Brahminical; everyone sees him chairing sessions in Brahminical institutions and receiving honors.

But Subhash Chandra Yadav remained stubborn. Because he has an ideology.

The 5-page introduction of 'Gulo: Art and Language' does not advance the criticism of Gulo; rather, it advances the blackmailing agenda of Brahminical institutions, and this time his target is 'Mithila Sanskrtik Parishad, Calcutta'. But this time his effort will prove futile, as will become clear later.

First, Harimohan Jha was the target of Brahminical institutions and individuals, not Yatri. Ramanath Jha's enemy was Harimohan Jha; he gaslighted him, and after Maithili's entry into Sahitya Akademi, Harimohan Jha stopped writing in Maithili altogether; giving him an award was out of the question! (For details, see my book Rajdeo Mandal – Maithili Writer, also available at the Videha Archive link http://videha.co.in/pothi.htm).

Mahakavi Vidyapati Thakur (1350-1435) – different from the first poet of Maithili, Jyotirishwar-pre Vidyapati; he wrote in Sanskrit and Avahattha. Vidyapati Thakkuraḥ, a resident of Bisfi-Kashyap (court poet of King Shivasimha), a Sanskrit and Avahattha writer. He produced numerous timeless works including Kirtilata, Kirtipatākā, Purusha Pariksha, Goraksha Vijaya, Likhanāvalī, etc. He is different from the first poet of Maithili, Vidyapati (pre-Jyotirishwar). The painting is based on one commissioned by Mithila Sanskrtik

Parishad, Kolkata, from an artist; the artist's name has been kept secret for 60-70 years for unknown reasons.

But this institution, Mithila Sanskrtik Parishad, was close to Yatriji. Yatriji was close to Ramanath Jha as well, and also to Sahitya Akademi. He used to be the chief guest at Brahminical institutions; Brahminical institutions had problems with Harimohan Jha, not Yatri.

Taranand Viyogi has no evidence of any accusation by Yatri against Mithila Sanskrtik Parishad; so he starts gossiping and introduces the language of Mohan Bhardwaj's 'khacharpnī' (accusation of embezzlement). The accusation of khacharpnī against Mithila Sanskrtik Parishad by Mohan Bhardwaj and Taranand Viyogi, and the accusation of losing manuscripts, is a criminal act. Does Mohan Bhardwaj or Taranand Viyogi have any evidence? The answer is no. Mithila Sanskrtik Parishad has many other shortcomings, but it published the literature of Yatri and Manipadmaka without any government aid, and neither Mohan Bhardwaj nor Taranand Viyogi have that morality. Mohan Bhardwaj is not alive to apologize, but if Taranand Viyogi has any morality left, he should immediately apologize to Mithila Sanskrtik Parishad. Taranand Viyogi is wasting his time on Mithila Sanskrtik Parishad; it is a declared Brahminical institution, just like Chetna Samiti and Vidyanath Jha 'Vidit', whose work he praises profusely after messing it up. But its financial condition is not such that it can just give a manuscript and get it printed. The writer of Balchanma, Nagarjun, had no problem with that book; nor does his son Shobhakant (whom Yatriji called Shobha Misar) consider that book to be in Maithili, and therefore it is not compiled in 'Yatri Samagra' (Rajkamal Prakashan). Mithila Sanskrtik Parishad is not a wealthy institution like Chetna Samiti; it prints a book only when donations are received; there is no room for any conspiracy theory. Furthermore, it rents a room at Navin Printing Press for one month a year to publish the monthly 'Baisar'. So expecting honor by blackmailing this institution is also futile. Third, it is not in Bihar; although Brahmins in Bihar might be scared seeing the current political situation, this institution in Calcutta does not have that fear.

Now, realizing that this critical book is on Subhash Chandra Yadav's 'Gulo', whose feet he is trying to butter, he turns to Gulo – but then he brings up Jagdish Prasad Mandal without naming him (there are two reasons for not naming

names in Brahminism and neo-Brahminism, actually two, not three: first, to avoid conflict; second, due to lack of evidence, some people would use this to further their own agenda; third, an inferiority complex – if we name them, that person's fame would increase; these three occur in different situations) – "Like novels being produced in Maithili in bulk..." This is another proof of Taranand Viyogi's neo-Brahminism; how did a non-Brahmin other than me get a Sahitya Akademi award? I am talented by birth, but he... but I won't name him. Kedar Kanan did the same when he wrote without naming Surendra Jha 'Suman', Chandranath Mishra 'Amar', Ramanath Jha, Vidyanath Jha 'Vidit', Mayanand Mishra, etc. – "Those who speak in big, high-sounding words are considered to be corrupting the language." Perhaps he could go that far. But all of them are/were close to the two editors; so how can they say they are being targeted, how can they explain it to people? All these facts are being documented for the purity of history. Brahminism and neo-Brahminism, with their same colour of deceit, are flourishing and blooming each other, and both are allies in opposing the parallel stream.

In the 5-page introduction of Taranand Viyogi's 'Gulo: Art and Language', only 5 lines are written about Gulo.

Kedar Nath Chaudhary expressed his inability to write an article. But the mention of Phanishwar Nath Renu's letter was good.

Mantreshwar Jha filled pages. He found Gulo touching and accurate, but I don't understand why paper should be wasted for this.

Ganganath Gangesh's favourite storyteller Rajmohan Jha was also there; the two editors could have edited this; when the government gives them both to edit, then they write; but perhaps Subhash Chandra Yadav is Ganganath Gangesh's favourite, so they didn't cut the lines. But this book is not about Subhash Chandra Yadav, only his Gulo. And now you must have understood how the two editors filled a 5-page review and 202 pages of articles on a 69-page Gulo. Actually, after one and a half pages, they come to Gulo.

Shobhakant (usually Shobha Misar) himself admits that he is not a person of any literary genre, but he has written a good summary.

Ramlochan Thakur got Gulo published in Mithila Darshan, and so he wrote a memoir, after giving some facts about Mithila first.

Ashok is basically a storyteller, so he took the relish, but could not critique it. Narayanji also wrote a memoir.

Kedar Kanan's memoir seems like Japanese novelist Haruki Murakami's 'Novelist as a Vocation', how a novel is written. There is nothing from a critical perspective, but if a writer like Subhash Chandra Yadav or another gave this reading to the reader, it would be a new story.

What Taranand Viyogi wants to write, he himself doesn't know. He wants to fill pages; by writing 'people', 'some people', etc., he maintains scope. I partially agree that after Ramanath Jha, Maithili criticism took a crooked path; mainstream criticism, which includes Taranand Viyogi and his associate Mohan Bhardwaj, starting with Ramanath Jha, took a crooked path. (Evidence – see the Sahitya Akademi sponsored 'Maithili Patra Patrika' book, where the Brahminical and neo-Brahminical perspectives of these gentlemen became very clear; Mohan Bhardwaj accuses Mithila Sanskrtik Parishad of khacharpnī, but they have done the same in this book. For details, see my book Rajdeo Mandal – Maithili Writer, also available at the Videha Archive link http://videha.co.in/pothi.htm). Here too, the opposition between Taranand Viyogi's ideology and Subhash Chandra Yadav's ideology is apparent; in Nit Naval Rajkamal, Subhash Chandra Yadav called Ramanath Jha's criticism traditionalist, and also said that he could not do justice to Rajkamal Chaudhary.

Ramesh Lalit-Kisun-Mayanand – putting everyone on the same scale; where is Lalit, where is Kisun, and where is Mayanand? But they need to maintain balance, otherwise they wouldn't publish the article; in mainstream criticism, criticism means praise.

Krishnamohan Jha 'Mohan' again writes a summary; Vaidyanath Jha, the Maithili novelists don't even know his name; Kumar Manish Arvind has just finished Gulo and, in the name of criticism, tries to balance – 'The style of the novel is not very advanced. Its structure is also not very organized. On one

hand, everything is said around. There is no attempt to organize it. But the language is so precise..' And then the balance; this language is pure. When you start writing without reading parallel stream Maithili, writers like him remain amazed.

The only meaningful article in this collection is Vidyanand Jha's "Latakal Chhi Muda Bachal Chhi: Bachal Rahbak Mahāākhyān, Gulo" (Hanging but Alive: The Grand Narrative of Remaining Alive, Gulo), which attacks Kedar Kanan, Taranand Viyogi, and others when he says – "There is no pornography of poverty." This is a meaningful comment on the book's emaciated state. This is not about the poor class, but a grand narrative of Mithila. Vidyanand Jha should have entered criticism, but due to fear of being marginalised by the mainstream, he cannot do so, because he is used to the easy path. But the echo of the attack he has made will resonate with the two editors for a long time.

Raman Kumar Singh, like Taranand Viyogi, is used to patronising; critics might think a ruckus is created, and "Yada yada hi dharmasya..." happens, then Taranand Viyogi and Raman Kumar Singh appear, and the world is saved. And those who criticise them are Brahmins. And such people we call neo-Brahminical. They primarily write book introductions, which they call criticism; the cover is good, the content is good, the depiction is beautiful, the language is good. Everything is very good, very beautiful.

Amidst the cannon fodder of the neo-Brahminical, Arun Kumar Singh writes – "During our stay in Mysore, when we questioned the learned writer about the language of his 1983 published 'Ghardekhiya' and 2009 published 'Banait Bigadait' Maithili story collections, he said that behind the language in his stories, there is a regional atmosphere, which we call the atmosphere of the earth." This also exposed Vidyanand Jha's review, which we described as an attack on the two editors.

In Satish Verma's "Mehnatkash Bahujan Samaj ka Mahākāvya" (The Epic of the Labouring Bahujan Samaj), he sees all the world's economic theories failing. He quotes –

"Chhotua gave the pyre. Gulo was buried with soil. Some people, who were watching this spectacle, among them a Muslim said to another Muslim, 'Are these Hindus or Muslims? They are giving fire and also burying.' The other Muslim said, 'Oh Allah! Did you see? They took him once, now they are burying him. Where will they get two paise? What religion do these Hindus have?' A third Muslim said, 'What does religion do? If there is money, children will survive.'"

And gives his verdict – "Like Kabir, he establishes a socio-religious-political dialogue." And this verdict is correct; the mullah who gives the call to prayer, first one speaks with Muslim superiority, then the other corrects him politically; and that other, according to Satish Verma, is Kabir, Subhash Chandra Yadav.

In Arunabh Saurabh's "Yātanāpūrṇa Vipanntākā Yathātath" (The Reality of Painful Destitution), the cannon fodder begins again. "Fewer novels are being written in Maithili literature." This is a verdict when the fact is the opposite; nowadays, after poetry, the most novels are being written. But he fears that if it is being written, then he arranges that – "If it has been written, it is not considered very capable of directly connecting with the reader's mind and restlessness." These are the problems of writing an article without reading, without study. After two or three pages of cannon fodder, he remembers that he also has to write about Gulo. The fault is not his but the editors', who consider editing mere proofreading. Still, the cannon fodder doesn't end, revealing his lack of study, especially the study of parallel literature.

Ashish Chaman writes – "The background of this story, which comes from the story of 'the last destitute person of society', is described verbatim from their mouths." We have already written that Kedar Kanan's preface to Gulo disrupts the reading of Gulo; not only does it disrupt, it also distorts and influences, as seen in Ashish Chaman's article.

Raghunath Mukhiya, in 'Gulok Bahanne Maithili Bhasha Par Vichar' (Thoughts on Maithili Language through Gulo), puts all the burden on Subhash Chandra Yadav and the parallel stream; Raghunath Mukhiya, like Taranand Viyogi, continues to write 'pure' Maithili.

Taranand Viyogi's mind is not satisfied; he brings another article "Pachpania Maithili: Ek Zamini Paricharcha – Facebook Post and Reactions and Controversies". Actually, I don't know what job he does; he spends all day on Facebook. But on Facebook in Maithili, he does not conduct any discussion; he immediately starts insults and squabbles; if any discussion does happen (in the mainstream), it has no more than 5-10 comments; we have banned more than 200 Brahminical and neo-Brahminical IDs from the Videha Facebook group, and today they are inactive accounts, because the theft was caught, but they can become active anytime; so the parallel stream keeps an eye on these sleeper cells. But again, the same thing – all the burden is on Subhash Chandra Yadav's shoulders and on the parallel stream; Raghunath Mukhiya and Taranand Viyogi continue to write 'pure' Maithili. But showing themselves as victims, associating themselves with Pachpania Maithili, and then claiming to share Subhash Chandra Yadav's ideology after participating in the conspiracy that gaslighted him – how false does this sound, and how much shamelessness is required for this? This is possible for Taranand Viyogi. Actually, you should read this cannon fodder between the Brahminical and neo-Brahminical. Both these classes are victims of split personality; they keep rubbing against each other, keep abusing each other (because of competition), but against the parallel stream and the Videha Maithili literature movement, they become one. Brahminism and neo-Brahminism are partners in deceit, but both keep flourishing and blooming each other.

And finally, in "Pachpania Maithili", Subhash Chandra Yadav attacks the two Sahitya Akademi award-winning editors again when he writes –

"Once Professor Indrakant Jha called – 'You should have received the Sahitya Akademi award earlier. You deserve it. I am an admirer of your stories. Your 'Banait-Bigadait' is at the top in the race. But its language is not correct. For the award, you will have to submit another collection with a different language.' In this context, a noteworthy fact is that in 'Banait Bigadait', the first story is in elite Maithili, and all the remaining stories are written in Pachpania Maithili."

And did you notice the time? This was the time when the Sahitya Akademi group, under the leadership of 'Vidit', was dancing naked, and at that same time, this group had awarded Taranand Viyogi for his 'pure' Maithili language, and

Taranand Viyogi had praised 'Vidit' profusely. I had written the preface for that 'Banait-Bigadait', which was sacrificed.

He is the author of "Kathak Banal Lok", which we read in 1983 and 1984 in 9th and 10th grade; he remained stubborn. After Ghardekhiya, even after 25 years, he remained stubborn with Banait Bigadait; and now Gulo, Madar, and Bhot. And behold the irony; the slap on Indrakant Jha's cheek was sweetened when Jagdish Prasad Mandal was given the 2021 Maithili Sahitya Akademi Award for his novel "Pangu" in Thethi/Pachpania spelling.

And finally, in "Pachpania Maithili", Subhash Chandra Yadav attacks the two Sahitya Akademi award-winning editors again when he writes –

"Dr. Ramanand Jha 'Raman' had noted in his notebook – 'Brahmins say Soit chhi, Solhakan says Bābhan chhi. What should I say, what is it?' In this note, the disrespect expressed for 'Solhakan' is nothing but a linguistic expression of caste hatred and disgust."

Ramanand Jha 'Raman' replied to Subhash Chandra Yadav on 10 December 2022, after my 'Nit Naval Subhashchandra Yadav (Part-1)' was published on 01 December 2022 in Videha; Dinesh Yadav from Nepal opposed it, and Lalitesh Mishra from India supported it.

Ramanand Jha 'Raman' - Amini (Surveyor) without Reading:

A surveyor measures the field. Surveying is not a song that one can sing or hum. It is a skill; without learning the surveying skill, what is the importance of the root-link? I cannot understand. If one link is missing here or there, brothers can start breaking heads. Similarly, a language surveyor must acquire knowledge of linguistics or language science. They can say this is a language, this is a dialect, this is a mixed language, this is a creole, etc. They can say what is the difference between spoken language and written language, common language and literary language, character's language and the author's language.

Ramanath Jha believes that 'Mithila language is not today's language. Its form stabilizes over time. The tradition of writing for six or seven hundred years has come here, and in the last fifty years, it is being corrupted by the influence of Hindi. The script went first; now the form of the language is being destroyed. Language is not a single thing that if everyone writes in different colours, then the language will not survive.'

There is a discipline for the protection and use of social property. Just as a bundle is necessary for stacking a field, similarly, a bundle (standardisation) is important for the prestige and acceptability of a language on national-international platforms. The Aminis of Mithila language have done this work.

George Abraham Grierson identified Mithila language on a linguistic basis, declared it an independent language, and determined the characteristics of its dialects. Maha Vyakaranacharya Dinabandhu Jha, M.M. Umesh Mishra, Acharya Ramanath Jha, Dr. Subhadra Jha, Pandit Shri Govind Jha, Dr. Ramavatar Yadav, Udayanarayan Singh 'Nachiketa', Yogendra Prasad Yadav, Dr. Sunil Kumar Jha, etc., by studying that science, gave Mithila language its global reach and prestige. But now such a ruckus has arisen or been created that no one cares. They neither respect Pandit Shri Govind Jha nor Dr. Ramavatar Yadav. They are poets of Maithili, storytellers, novelists, critics, politically motivated social workers, and above all, they have become linguists without studying the science.

See Dinesh Yadav's reply:

First, the speakers of the language should be surveyed; it will be easier to reach a conclusion quickly. Grammar is needed, but what kind? Standard is needed, but who should determine it? The people will now reject the Brahminical style, commentary, or standard. Maithili speakers are not as naive as before; everyone has become intelligent. We write and read Maithili, but the Brahmins do not accept our dialect, style, and language variety as standard... ! So it is necessary to abandon this ancient thinking and poor mentality and move forward with new veins. Now the tradition of being rewarded by praising and going around Ganesha must be ended. Until a sociological, psychological perspective is developed, Maithili will remain confined to caste-based philosophy, beliefs,

and ideas. That confinement only causes loss and more loss to Maithili. Scientific thinking, equal treatment, multi-caste acceptance, inclusion of various dialects, etc., are the medicines for Maithili to survive; if we adopt them and move forward, it is not too late. Maithili will shine and sparkle!

But Lalitesh Mishra's support came to Ramanand Jha 'Raman'; however, his cunning, as he pretends to call Subhash Chandra Yadav a newcomer/Facebooker, etc. So we have named this behaviour of his as 'Puranic criticism', context-dependent. As the platform, so is the criticism; in Garuda Purana, Garuda is above Brahma-Vishnu-Mahesh, and in Matsya Purana, Matsya is above Brahma-Vishnu-Mahesh.

Lalitesh Mishra's Support for Ramanand Jha 'Raman'

... Not everyone needs guidance. Such people guide themselves. They consider themselves experts in all subjects. They have no need for any linguist. Maithili has already developed a lot. A new age of knowledge has arrived. Now there is no need to show the way. Inviting a granary to store knowledge is what is needed.

But our mother's teaching is no less – it was written in a book of Maithili proverbs – "Ten Brahmins ten bellies, ten Rar one belly" – then he learned that this is wrong; this is what Brahmins say; for Brahmins, the other class says – "Ten Brahmins one belly." I don't know what kind of education Ramanand Jha 'Raman' and Lalitesh Mishra received.

But what both are doing is understood by them, and it is being exposed here. Ramanand Jha 'Raman' writes – "They can say this is a language, this is a dialect, this is a mixed language, this is a creole, etc." Do you see any conspiracy in this? Then see what conspiracy this is.

English is also spoken as a mother tongue and as a second language, and in addition, there are many kinds of Pidgin English and Creole English. Pidgin English is also divided into two classes – Atlantic Pidgin and Pacific Pidgin. Atlantic Pidgin English developed in West Africa and spread to the West Indies

and America through the slave trade, but in this region, Pidgin speakers were considered stupid and lazy. But this is not true for Pacific Pidgin; it developed in Hawaii, Papua New Guinea, and other British colonies, due to trade compulsions; in New Guinea, Creole is the national language, because it developed, increased its vocabulary, and also sentence structure. What is Pidgin? It is a means of communication between two groups of people who speak two different languages; Pidgin is no one's mother tongue. Over time, Pidgin becomes the mother tongue of some people, and then it is called Creole. English-based Pidgin and Creole spread in British colonies, where it became a medium of communication between the British masters and the local people. Pidgin and Creole are called non-standard forms of English. They are like limited systems, with limited structure and vocabulary. Now you must be laughing at Raman's ignorance, who calls the Maithili of the parallel stream, with a vocabulary of over a lakh words and thousands of sentence structures, a creole, while the Maithili based on 2000 words and 50 sentence structures is the original. But you may hold your stomach and sit, because Ramanand Jha 'Raman' and Lalitesh Mishra will make you laugh even more at their ignorance.

Hawaiian Pidgin

English – Sometimes there is a good road.

Hawaiian Pidgin – Samtem, gud rod get

English – Sometimes there are things like bends, angles, right?

Hawaiian Pidgin – Samtem, olseim ben get, enguru get, no?

Cameroon Pidgin

English – Go.

Cameroon Pidgin – Go. (no change)

English – Don't go.

Cameroon Pidgin – No go.

English – They can go.

Cameroon Pidgin – Dem fit go.

English – They can't go.

Cameroon Pidgin – Dem no fit go.

English – Nobody came.

Cameroon Pidgin – No man no bin kam.

Nigerian Pidgin

English – Government! All our roads are ruined completely.

Nigerian Pidgin – Gofrumet! Ol our roads don yamutu finish.

English – Please make somebody come from the government even if it is from Kano.

Nigerian Pidgin – Biko make somebody gofumenet efen i fit from Kano com sef.

English – Anyone who is available sir, let him just get something done.

Nigerian Pidgin – Anywans at all af labulu sa, make i jus find samtingz don for.

English – All these roads are in a woeful state.

Nigerian Pidgin – Ol dis road dem way don wowo finish.

Chinese Coastal Pidgin

English – He is/was very sick.

Chinese Coastal Pidgin – He plenti sick.

English – I am the chief boy.

Chinese Coastal Pidgin – Mai blong number-one boi.

English – This is an excellent book.

Chinese Coastal Pidgin – Dis a numba one gud buk.

(Crystal D.: The English Language, Penguin Books, England, 1990)

Now come to the conspiracy. What does Ramanand Jha 'Raman' want to say? The master-servant relation in language, or has Pidgin Maithili become Creole Maithili? Or does he want to say nothing because he has no knowledge on this subject, only wants to confuse due to ignorance? Such talk is called 'bakthothi' in our village, and it is not considered good. And so Ramanand Jha 'Raman', who is a surveyor without reading, and who, in his favour, counted names like Ramavatar Yadav, Yogendra Prasad Yadav, Sunil Kumar Jha, etc. (which is called name-dropping in Delhi and is not considered good), proves that he has made a bibliography without reading their books, by typing keywords into a Google search. Yogendra Prasad Yadav's English articles have even been e-published in Videha; if he had read them, his perspective would have been a bit clearer; Ramavatar Yadav has research in favour of Subhash Chandra Yadav; so it is clear that he is a surveyor without reading.

Subhash Chandra Yadav writes –

"The grammarians of Maithili have prepared grammatical frameworks of Sanskrit and Hindi. They did not consider the specificity and difference of Dalit Maithili worthy of consideration. Dr. Ramavatar Yadav is the only linguist who has given some thought to this."

Subhash Chandra Yadav writes again –

"Once, there was a programme at the Anugrah Narayan Sinha Institute of Social Studies, Patna. The Central Institute of Indian Languages, Mysore, had organized this programme. The main concern of the programme was the

development of the Maithili language. Various speakers gave their speeches on how development would happen. Dr. Meghan Prasad also expressed his views. His language did not have as much respectfulness as the scholarly group expected. The result was that during his speech, he was mocked very rudely for his linguistic slip. This scene disturbed me, and I immediately protested against such linguistic intolerance."

An article by Meghan Prasad, which was read at this seminar of the Central Institute of Indian Languages, Mysore, was published in the magazine 'Ghar Bahar' of Ramanand Jha 'Raman's so-called literary association, without the first paragraph (Ramanand Jha 'Raman' is an expert at this), but that article was later e-published in Videha in its entirety. And you must have understood which fact was being attempted to be censored through that cunning? Meghan Prasad had written that he had expressed his desire several times to get translation assignments from Sahitya Akademi, but the Sahitya Akademi, which loves him, never gave him any assignment. Now you must understand why the mainstream and Sahitya Akademi consider Meghan Prasad and Subhash Chandra Yadav outsiders, and why Taranand Viyogi is acceptable.

Subhash Chandra Yadav writes –

"The Maithili of the pag-dopatā (braid and headcloth) will continue, but the Maithili of the gol-golā (a type of song or dialect) will survive."

And the painting of Vidyapati of gol-golā that you see in this essay was made by Videha Samman awardee Panakalal Mandal; the Vidyapati of the Padavali, the pre-Jyotirishwar Vidyapati, is the logo of Videha.

The painting of the pag-dopatā, of Sanskrit and Avahattha, was commissioned by Mithila Sanskrtik Parishad, Kolkata, from some artist, and the name of that artist has been kept secret for 60-70 years for unknown reasons.

An e-letter from Subhash Chandra Yadav Ji is also given below, which comments on the casteism storm in Maithili literature.

Mayanand Mishra – Kurukshetram – We oppose the opposition to my novel 'Stridhan' in Antarmanak. I worked so hard; it was praised at J.N.U., and you opposed it (someone from behind is telling me to keep quiet, I am panting).

Gajendra Thakur – (My comment given in Videha) – Criticism should not be considered opposition.

Subhash Chandra Yadav (8 November 2009, chandra.yadav.subhash@gmail.com) – E-mail message –

Gajendra Babu, Maya Babu has been understood that he is a great opportunist, casteist, sycophant, and intolerant; I have never been close to him. Even living in the same city, I never met Maya Babu. He is a very selfish and self-centred person. At first, I am pained by these thoughts and reactions, but it is good that I do not care about them and recover quickly. Your fight is for truth. You are engaged with complete dedication, strength, and hope for the proper development of language, literature, and folk culture; your ideals are constantly being realized. Regards.

Subhash Chandra Yadav reminded me of my father – 27 years after his death, I don't know from where a touch came into my eyes –

I had seen my father holding on to truth in stability

Then I understood that

No sacrifice had been made

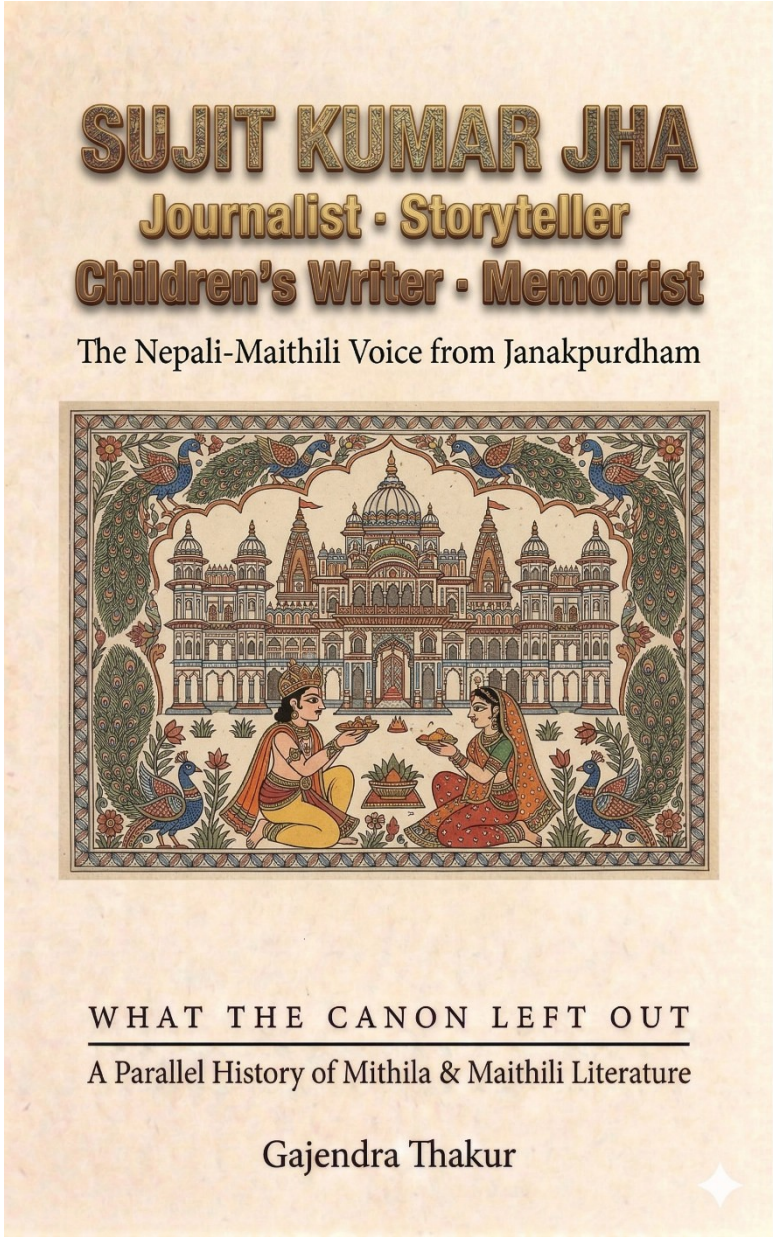
This is the path for the stubborn.

Mother asked if she had performed the Ratuka worship. Riniya's mind was not in hearing about the events. The mother said – 'Mother, I don't have money. I will bring medicine for Father.' (Gulo, novel 2015)

In 1995, I came home from training without any reason; I was restless. Mother asked about the training; I did not feel like talking about it. I asked about Father's mood. He was lying on the cot. He would get up at 3 PM to have tea. After eating, the plate was kept; I covered it with another plate; Father was sleeping, a Sunday afternoon. I would eat when he woke up. Is his mood okay? At 3 PM, Mother went to wake Father with tea... Father did not wake up. (A true incident that happened to me, 1995)

(With the permission of Subhash Chandra Yadav Ji, his entire literature is available at the Videha Petar http://videha.co.in/pothi.htm)

**LESSON 087 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**



# A COMPLETE CRITICAL RESEARCH AND APPRECIATION OF THE WORKS OF SUJIT KUMAR JHA

Journalist · Storyteller · Children's Writer · Memoirist

The Nepali-Maithili Voice from Janakpurdham

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Analysed through Indian & Western Literary Theories,

the Videha Parallel History Framework, and

Navya Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya

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## PREFACE

This research constitutes a complete critical appreciation of the literary works of Sujit Kumar Jha (सुजीत कुमार भा / सुजित कुमार झा), a Nepali Maithili journalist, short-story writer, children's author, and memoirist based in Janakpurdham, Dhanusha District, Nepal. Eight of his published texts are analysed as primary sources: the short-story collections Chiṛai (चिड़ै), Jiddī (जिद्दी), Bulbul (बुलबुल), Gandha (गन्ध), and Khajurībālī (खजुरीबाली); the children's story collection Koilī Ghūri Āu (कोइली घूरि आउ); the journalistic memoir-essay collection Reporter Diary (रिपोर्टर डायरी); and a feature article in the Doodhmati Weekly newspaper (Ank 41, 15 March 2016).

The critical methodology interlaces three frameworks: (i) Classical Indian literary theory — rasa-dhvani aesthetics, alaṃkāra, and aucitya; (ii) Western critical theory from Aristotle through Russian Formalism, New Criticism, feminist theory, postcolonialism, and narratology; and (iii) the Videha Parallel

History Framework of Gajendra Thakur, which recovers the suppressed democratic, Nepal-side, and non-institutional strand of Maithili literature. Threading through all three frameworks is the epistemological precision of Navya Nyāya, the 'New Logic' school founded by Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya of Mithilā (14th century CE), whose Tattvacintāmaṇi provides a rigorous vocabulary for distinguishing valid inference from conjecture.

Sujit Kumar Jha is a figure of particular significance in the Videha Parallel History: he is a Nepal-side Maithili author — one of that community of writers in the Madhesh / Terai region whose work is systematically marginalised by both the India-centric Sahitya Akademi establishment and mainstream Nepali literary institutions. His texts are simultaneously rooted in Mithilā's ancient cultural soil and alive to contemporary urban-rural tensions, migration, gender, journalistic ethics, and childhood. The Nepal Bidyapati Maithili Research Prize awarded to him by the Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation of Nepal (c. 2014) marks an institutional recognition of precisely the kind the Videha Parallel History has long advocated.

# PART I: BIOGRAPHICAL AND CONTEXTUAL PORTRAIT

## 1.1 Life and Vocation

Sujit Kumar Jha was born on Baisakh 11, Vikram Samvat 2033 (approximately April–May 1976) in the village of Lohana Bhamnagama-2, Ward No. 2, Dhanusha District, Nepal. His father is Shri Sukhendra Jha; his mother is Jayamangala Devi — to both of whom he dedicates his first story collection Chiṛai in an inscription of filial devotion that marks the emotional centre of his creative project. His permanent residence is Saraswati Nagar, Janakpurdham-4, Nepal (email: sujitjha100.80@gmail.com). He holds an MA in Maithili and is pursuing a second year of post-graduate study in Sociology — a dual academic formation that combines the humanistic study of language and literature with the social-scientific analysis of community, making him, at the level of intellectual formation, a writer unusually equipped to move between individual emotion and social structure.

Professionally, Jha has been a journalist for over two decades. At the time of the publication of Chiṛai, he served as News Chief of Radio Mithila 100.8 MHz, Janakpurdham; Editor of Mithila Dotcom Daily; and Television Correspondent

for ABN Television, Kathmandu. His earlier affiliations include Channel Nepal TV, Spacetime Daily, Rastriya Samachar Samiti (the national news agency of Nepal), Nepal Samacharpatr Daily, Lokpatr Daily, Janakpur Today Daily, and Vishwadeep Weekly — a career spanning broadcast, print, digital, and wire-service journalism across the full range of Nepali media. He is affiliated with the Central Press Club and the Nepal Press Mahāsangh (Federation of Nepali Journalists), Dhanusha Chapter.

His awards include the ABN News Integrity Honour (2066 BS), Radio Mithila Samman (2065 BS), and the Mithila Samman from the Mithila Nāṭya Kalā Pariṣad (2068 BS). Most significantly, he received the Nepal Bidyapati Maithili Research Prize (NPR 1,00,000) from the Ministry of Culture, Tourism and Civil Aviation of Nepal — the highest state recognition for Maithili language and literature contribution in Nepal — an award confirmed by The Rising Nepal Daily and the Bidyapati Prize Fund, Janakpurdham.

## 1.2 The Nepal-Side Maithili Context

Maithili is spoken by approximately 13–14 million people across the India-Nepal border region: in North Bihar (India) and in the Terai / Madhesh belt of Nepal, where it is constitutionally recognised as a national language and is the second most spoken language of Nepal after Nepali. The Nepal-side Maithili literary tradition — running from the Malla-era Sanskrit-Maithili court poetry of Kathmandu Valley through the 20th-century Janakpur literary flowering — is systematically underrepresented in India-focused literary histories and in the Sahitya Akademi's institutional apparatus.

Jha's Janakpurdham is not a peripheral location but a symbolic and cultural centre: it is the city of Sītā, the birthplace of Mithilā's patron goddess and the sacred geography around which Maithili literature's oldest devotional energies cluster. Writing from Janakpurdham is therefore simultaneously a marginalised geopolitical act (outside the Sahitya Akademi's Indian purview) and a culturally central one (at the heart of Maithili civilisational memory). The Videha Parallel History explicitly valorises this Nepal-side location as part of the tradition's democratic, non-institutionalised, living dimension.

Aaphanta Nepal (the publisher of Jiddī, Bulbul, and Koilī Ghūri Āu), Shri Ramanand Yuva Club, Janakpurdham (publisher of Chiṛai and Gandha), and Jay Mangala Devi Prakashan Griha, Janakpurdham (publisher of Khajurībālī) represent the local literary infrastructure of the Nepal-side parallel tradition: small, community-rooted publishers operating without institutional subsidy, sustained by the voluntary literary labour of writers like Jha.

# PART II: THEORETICAL FRAMEWORKS

## 2.1 Indian Classical Theory

### *Rasa-Dhvani and the Reader-as-Sahṛdaya*

Bharata Muni's Nāṭyaśāstra (c. 200 BCE–200 CE) establishes the eight rasas — śṛṅgāra (love/beauty), hāsya (comedy), karuṇa (compassion/pathos), raudra (fury), vīra (heroism), bhayānaka (terror), bībhatsa (disgust), adbhuta (wonder) — later supplemented by śānta (peace/serenity). Abhinavagupta's Abhinavabhāratī (c. 1000 CE) deepens this into a theory of aesthetic universalisation: the sahṛdaya (cultivated reader) does not merely feel an emotion but savours its generalised, de-personalised form — a rasa, a flavour, that arises at the intersection of the text's evocative elements and the reader's cultivated imagination.

Ānandavardhana's dhvani (resonance or suggestion, c. 850 CE) argues that the truest poetic meaning inheres in a third semantic layer beyond literal denotation (abhidhā) and figurative indication (lakṣaṇā): it is resonance, what the text whispers rather than says. Applied to Jha's fiction: the surface of 'Chiṛai' (bird) stories is often a simple, domestic, social-realist narrative, but the dhvani — the resonant undertone — is always larger: the story of a woman in 'Vāṇājī' (the kite-woman) reverberates with the dhvani of female dignity submerged beneath social demand; the story of migration in 'Choṭasan bāt' resonates with the entire sociology of Nepal's youth diaspora.

### *Vakrokti, Alaṃkāra, and Aucitya*

Kuntaka's vakrokti ('oblique expression', c. 950 CE) identifies the characteristic 'swerve' of poetic language from the prosaic norm as the source of literary pleasure. Jha's titles consistently demonstrate vakrokti at the level of naming: 'Jiddī' (stubborn/obstinate) applied to a character who refuses social scripts; 'Gandha' (smell/fragrance) as the title of an erotic-social collection in which the body's olfactory register carries the entire weight of emotional complexity; 'Khajurībālī' (the date-palm girl/woman) as a figure who is at once rooted (the tree) and bearing sweetness (the fruit), a complex metaphor for female resilience.

Mammaṭa's Kāvyaprakāśa insists on three qualities in great kāvya: freedom from doṣa (blemish), positive guṇas (excellence of expression), and appropriate alaṃkāra (ornament). Kṣemendra's aucitya (propriety) demands that every element — character, plot, diction, emotion — suit its context. In Jha's short fiction, the principle of aucitya operates as the governing formal principle: his diction is consistently calibrated to character — urban, educated dialogue for middle-class characters; rural, idiomatic Maithili for village figures; a reporter's clipped, factual register in the journalistic essays of Reporter Diary.

## 2.2 Navya Nyāya: Gaṅgeśa as Epistemological Model

### *The Tattvacintāmaṇi and the Four Pramāṇas*

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (fl. c. 1325 CE, Karion village near Darbhanga, Mithilā) composed the Tattvacintāmaṇi ('The Jewel of Thought on the Nature of Things'), founding the Navya Nyāya ('New Logic') school. His four khaṇḍas (books) correspond to the four pramāṇas — means of valid knowledge: pratyakṣa (direct perception), anumāna (inference), upamāna (comparison), and śabda (verbal testimony). Gaṅgeśa's philosophical innovation lay in his precise technical metalanguage: the concepts of viśeṣyatā (objecthood), prakāratā (qualifier-hood), and the various forms of saṃsarga (relational connection) allow him to describe the structure of any cognition with extraordinary exactness.

The Videha Parallel History (Parts 16–20) has documented how Gaṅgeśa's biography was partly suppressed by establishment Maithilī historiography — original Panji (genealogical) records showing his cross-caste birth were concealed by Ramanath Jha. This biographical suppression mirrors the larger institutional suppression of non-canonical writers like Jha. The epistemological framework Gaṅgeśa developed — demanding that every critical judgement be traceable to a valid pramāṇa, and every inference backed by vyāpti (universal concomitance) — provides a rigorous model for literary criticism that transcends institutional authority.

### *Applying Navya Nyāya to Jha's Fiction*

Pratyakṣa (direct perception) in literary criticism corresponds to the close reading of the primary text: what is actually on the page, what specific words, images, and structures the author deploys. Anumāna (inference) moves from these textual signs to larger structures of meaning: what does the pattern of titles (all bird/nature metaphors in Chiṛai, Bulbul, Koilī Ghūri Āu) infer about

Jha's ecological and feminine symbolic lexicon? Upamāna (comparison) calibrates Jha against the tradition — against the Nepali Maithili predecessor Dr. Dhīrendra (whose influence is acknowledged in the critical essay 'Rachanātmak Bimarśak Ayanāme Chiṛai' by Chandresh that prefaces the first collection), against the Indian-Maithili tradition of Rajkamal Chaudhary, and against global short-story traditions. Śabda (verbal testimony) draws on the prefaces, reviews, and institutional records that contextualise and validate interpretive claims.

## 2.3 Western Critical Theories

### *Russian Formalism and Defamiliarisation*

Viktor Shklovsky's concept of ostranenie ('defamiliarisation', 1917) — the literary device that makes the familiar strange, restoring direct perception — is central to Jha's aesthetic strategy. In 'Dhūnik Bhītar' (Inside the Smoke, the opening story of Khajurībālī), the familiar domestic act of cooking is rendered strange by the focus on smoke as a medium of psychological interiority: the kitchen's haze becomes the character's mental fog. Jha's titles themselves perform ostranenie: 'Gandha' (Smell) as a story collection title defamiliarises the normal expectation of literary abstraction, anchoring meaning in the body's most intimate, instinctive sense.

### *New Criticism: Organic Unity, Paradox, Ambiguity*

Cleanth Brooks's 'well-wrought urn' principle and William Empson's seven types of ambiguity jointly illuminate Jha's craft. The best stories in Chiṛai and Jiddī are 'well-wrought urns': self-contained, organically unified artefacts in which every element — the opening image, the central conflict, the closing turn — is necessary and sufficient. Jha's signature technique, noted by internal critic Dr. Rājendra Vimal in the Jiddī foreword, is what Vimal calls 'karaṇṭ' (current): a story that begins from seemingly ordinary events and gathers, through the middle, an unstoppable momentum before arriving at a 'shocking yet inevitable' ending — precisely what Brooks would call the 'tension' and 'paradox' of successful poetic structure.

### *Postcolonialism and the Nepal-India Border Identity*

Homi Bhabha's concept of cultural hybridity and the 'third space' of enunciation — the liminal zone between cultures where new meanings are produced — describes Jha's creative situation with precision. As a Maithili writer in Nepal, he inhabits a third space between Nepali national literary culture and the India-

centred Maithili establishment: belonging fully to neither, he speaks from an interstitial position that is simultaneously marginalising and creatively enabling. Edward Said's Orientalism illuminates how the Madhesh/Terai identity is doubly Orientalised — as 'provincial' from Kathmandu's perspective and as 'non-Indian' from the Sahitya Akademi's perspective. Jha's creative response is not to perform either centre but to write directly from the Janakpurdham borderland, making its specific social textures — the radio journalist's world, the Terai town's contradictions, the daily lives of women and children — the very substance of Maithili modernity.

### *Feminist Narratology*

Sandra Gilbert and Susan Gubar's The Madwoman in the Attic and bell hooks's feminist standpoint theory provide the critical tools for reading the representation of women that dominates Jha's fiction. The internal critical essay on Chiṛai (by Chandresh, included as a preface) notes that 'most stories in Gandha are women-centred, based on love and desire' — and cautions that the author must be careful not to let the romantic surface obscure the deeper social critique. The stories 'Vāṇājī' (the woman who fights for dignity against death-like social erasure), 'Priyankā' (the woman who escapes the cage of 'dehaik bhog' — bodily consumption), 'Varkheṭhī Bhoj' (the meal at the feast — a woman's spiritual self-assertion against patriarchal religious prescription), and 'Kul' (lineage — where female identity is contested against patrilineal claims) together constitute a sustained feminist counter-narrative within the Maithili short-story tradition.

### *Children's Literature Theory: Maria Nikolajeva and Perry Nodelman*

Koilī Ghūri Āu (the Cuckoo Returns) — Jha's only explicitly children's story collection — invites analysis through the theoretical lens of children's literature studies. Perry Nodelman's The Hidden Adult argues that all children's literature encodes an adult ideological perspective that is simultaneously presented and concealed; Maria Nikolajeva's Power, Voice and Subjectivity in Literature for Young Readers examines the child's subject-position in narrative. Jha's children's stories use the natural world of Mithilā — birds, trees, the river, the koel's call — as a symbolic vocabulary that both delights the child reader and encodes adult messages about community, ecology, and belonging. The Maithili-speaking child reading about the koel's return hears simultaneously a nature story and a story about the return of Maithili culture to its own landscape.

### *The Reporter's Gaze: New Journalism and the Essay*

Tom Wolfe's New Journalism and Gay Talese's essays establish a tradition of literary non-fiction in which journalistic subject-matter is rendered through novelistic techniques: scene-by-scene construction, dialogue, point of view, and symbolic detail. Jha's Reporter Diary (97 pages, with 35+ essay-sketches ranging from 'Tower banabe kartai muda nagarkaṃ bikās' — the tower gets built but the city doesn't develop — through 'Vivāha kārdme Maithilī bhāṣā' — Maithili on the wedding card — to 'Chorā kaṣ velenṭāin' — Valentine's for the thief) exemplifies this tradition in Maithili. The essay topics reveal a journalist-essayist whose cultural criticism ranges from political satire to linguistic advocacy to social comedy.

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# PART III: THE VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY FRAMEWORK

## 3.1 The Parallel History and Nepal-Side Maithili

Gajendra Thakur's 'A Parallel History of Mithila and Maithili Literature' (Videha e-journal, ISSN 2229-547X, Parts 1–47+) argues that the official Maithili canon — as curated by the Sahitya Akademi since 1965 — systematically excludes democratic, folk, Dalit, feminist, and Nepal-side traditions. The Parallel History identifies the Nepal-side Malla-era literary output as equally central to Maithili literary history, not as a regional footnote. An RTI exposé by Vinit Utpal and Ashish Anchinhar (2011–14) confirmed that over 90% of Sahitya Akademi assignments went to ten advisory board members' personal networks — structurally excluding writers like Sujit Kumar Jha who are simultaneously geographically and institutionally peripheral.

Jha's work participates in what the Parallel History calls the 'Digital Era' Maithili (2000–present): the period when internet platforms, radio, and community publishing networks have enabled a grassroots literary renaissance outside institutional control. His role as Radio Mithila 100.8 MHz News Chief is itself a form of literary activism: radio is the medium through which Maithili reaches the Nepal Terai's semi-literate agrarian communities, communities that the print-literary establishment does not serve. Every news broadcast in Maithili is an act of linguistic preservation and democratisation.

### 3.2 The Journalist-Writer Tradition in the Parallel History

The Parallel History traces a lineage of journalist-writers in Maithili who have functioned as the language's public intellectuals outside the academic establishment. Rajkamal Chaudhary — identified by the Parallel History as the 'true avant-garde of Maithili' — was also a journalist. Harimohan Jha — the great anti-caste satirist whom the Sahitya Akademi denied even when the year went unrewarded — wrote for popular audiences. Jha stands in this tradition: his journalism and his fiction are not separate vocations but a single project of bearing witness, documenting social life with the observational precision the reporter's craft trains and the emotional depth the fiction writer's sensibility deepens.

The Doodhmati Weekly feature (Ank 41, 15 March 2016, Janakpurdham) in which Jha wrote demonstrates this integration: a newspaper that publishes in both Maithili and Nepali, with articles ranging from Janakpur's civic beautification projects and floods, to political commentary, to a discussion of the Nepal Patkaar Mahāsangh's annual meeting — all of this is the social fabric from which his fiction is drawn, and which his fiction, in turn, illuminates with an inner life that journalism cannot provide.

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## PART IV: CRITICAL APPRECIATION OF THE EIGHT PRIMARY TEXTS

### 4.1 Chiṛai (चिड़ै) — Short Stories

***Bibliographic Details***

Title: Chiṛai (Bird). Genre: Maithilī Kathā Saṃgraha (short-story collection). Author: Sujīt Kumār Bhā (Sujit Kumar Jha). Publisher: Shrī Rāmānanda Yuvā Club, Janakpurdham. First edition: VS 2069 (c. 2012 CE). Copies: 1,000. Copyright: Author. Price: ₹200 (institutional: ₹300). Cover design: Kelaas Daas. ISBN: 976-9937-2-3488-7. Printer: (not identified; the imprint page is partially unclear in the scanned facsimile). Pages: 61. Dedication: 'To the lotus-feet of our birth-giving mother Jayamangala Devi and father Sukhendra Jha' — signed Sujīt Kumār Bhā.

The collection is prefaced by a substantial critical essay, 'Rachanātmak Bimarśak Ayanāme Chiṛai' (In the Mirror of Creative Criticism: Chiṛai), written

by Chandresh. This essay is itself a primary critical document of considerable value, and is analysed separately below (4.1.3).

### *Stories and Themes*

Chiṛai is Jha's debut story collection and the text through which he established his reputation as one of the most 'lokpriya' (popularly beloved) short-story writers in Nepal's Maithili literary world — a characterisation confirmed both by the Jiddī back-cover blurb (signed by Dharmendr Jhā, former chairman of the Nepal Press Mahāsangh) and by the publisher Dipendra Thakur of Shri Ramanand Yuva Club (in the prefatory note 'Prakāśakīya'). The publisher notes that the club's literary publication programme had stalled for a year before Jha's manuscript arrived, and that after reading the stories the decision to publish was immediate.

From the table of contents (partially visible in the scanned facsimile), the collection includes stories that trace a map of contemporary Terai social life: stories of official empty words and bureaucratic betrayal; of the politics of village water resources; of the Patna-bound migrant who hears his mother's voice in memory; of a young woman at the threshold of adulthood confronting social surveillance; and stories in which love persists as an ethical imperative against social coercion. The Chandresh essay identifies the collection's central preoccupation as the tension between love and social propriety: 'Prem jīvanak aham hisstā thik, nakārā nakarā sarāsar vedmānī hoyat... Prem dañś tateka mārak hoyat achhi je ātmhartayā dhari karavāk lel lok uthata bha jāit achhi.'

Formally, the stories in Chiṛai operate in the tradition of the Maithili laprek — compressed, single-moment fiction — but they exceed the minimalism of the pure laprek by building character interiority with a novelist's patience. The Chandresh essay notes that Jha writes from within his characters' emotional worlds rather than observing from outside: 'Bhabukate pravahit hoit hunaka kathā āveśī svar nene achhi' (His stories flow with an emotive, passionate voice). The dominant rasa is śṛṅgāra — love-rasa in both its sambhoga (union) and vipralambha (separation) modes — but it is consistently socialised: the obstacles to love are not personal but structural, arising from caste hierarchy, economic inequality, and patriarchal surveillance.

### *The Chandresh Essay: A Critical Document*

The prefatory critical essay by Chandresh deserves separate attention as the most sustained engagement with Jha's work by a Nepali critic. Chandresh identifies three main thematic layers in Chiṛai: (i) the psychology of love and

desire, including the dangers of romantic obsession; (ii) the critique of capitalist-patriarchal social structures as they determine individual lives; and (iii) the persistence of human agency and dignity against these structures. The essay situates Jha within the Nepal Maithili short-story tradition by comparing him favourably with Dr. Dhīrendra — 'of whose two thousand-plus creations perhaps half are literature' (a critical barb that places Jha in a discriminating tradition rather than flattering him by simple comparison) — and with the tradition of Rambharos Kapadi 'Bhramar', Dr. Revatī Ramaṇ Lāl, Dr. Rājendra Prasad 'Vimal', Ayodhyānāth Chaudhary, and Bhuvaneśvar Pathey.

Applying Navya Nyāya to Chandresh's essay: his critical judgements are grounded in pratyakṣa (quotation from specific stories), anumāna (inference about Jha's larger aesthetic aims), and upamāna (calibration against the tradition). The essay's weakness, by the same standard, is that it moves occasionally from anumāna to speculation without adequate vyāpti (concomitance): the claim that Jha's romantic subject-matter makes him vulnerable to a 'bhogavādī dṛṣṭikoṇ' (hedonistic perspective) is an inference that requires closer textual substantiation than Chandresh provides.

### *Critical Assessment: Chiṛai*

Chiṛai is a landmark debut collection in contemporary Nepal-side Maithili fiction. Its formal accomplishment — the balance between emotional intensity and social observation; the compression of significant meaning into short narrative arcs; the consistent deployment of dhvani (resonance) through title and image — marks Jha as a writer working at the highest level of the Maithili short-story tradition. The collection's deployment of śṛṅgāra rasa as a vehicle for social critique is particularly notable: where the mainstream tradition of Maithili love-poetry celebrates śṛṅgāra within a courtly or devotional frame (Vidyapati's Rādhā-Kṛṣṇa padavalī), Jha deploys love as a materialist-feminist category, a force that reveals and contests social power.

## 4.2 Jiddī (जिद्दी) — Short Stories

### *Bibliographic Details*

Title: Jiddī (Stubborn/Obstinate). Genre: Kathā Saṃgraha (short stories). Publisher: Āphanta Nepal, Kathmandu. First edition: VS 2069 (c. 2012 CE). Copies: 1,900. Price: ₹300. Cover design: Felaas Daas. ISBN: M 978-9937-2-4674-3. Printer: Hāṃs Aphasèṭ Prinṭarsa, Jamal, Kathmandu. Pages: 62.

Dedication: 'To the memory of maternal grandmother Shiveshwari Devi and paternal grandfather Vishwambhar Jha — with devotion.'

The back cover carries three blurbs: (i) Dharmendr Jhā, former chairman of the Nepal Press Mahāsangh: 'Sujīt parīcaya mohtāj nahi chhathi. Jo āba samaja, saceta āu sachesta jambhānā jāit achhi. Prastut kṛti hunaka parīcaya svayaṃ daS rahi achhi.' ('Sujit needs no introduction. He is now wise, aware, and admirably conscientious. This work introduces him by itself.'); (ii) Dr. Vijay Kumar Singh, senior physician, Janakpur: 'Patrakarite jekaṃ kalthāme teno sujīt spaṣṭ sandeśa devāk prayās karāit chhi. Sāhityakārak kalamme sujīt dṛḍhakataṃ saṅg deṅg āgu baṛhone chhi. Sāhitvak śikhitajara pahūṃcavāk sambhāvanā hunakāṅe dekhvā jāhach.' ('Through journalism Sujit always tries to deliver clear messages. As a man of letters, he marches forward with great conviction. There is every possibility of reaching the peaks of literature.'); (iii) Ayodhyānāth Chaudhary, Coordinator, Vidyapati Puraskar Koṣ: 'Kathakar sujīta Nepālīye Maithilī kathā jagalame sarvādhika saccannāśīl prabhāvit chhathi. Prāya: saba kathaame āgu kia bhel ī didākhāla anta-darśi kanal rahhait achhi. Pāṭha nirmāṇame nipuṇ chhi, ena thiṅkame upanyāskar hevāk pracur sambhāvanā dekhāit chhī.' ('As a storyteller, Sujit is the most technically skilled and socially impactful among Nepal-side Maithili writers. His stories have an inner vision that points forward. He is accomplished in text construction, and in this writer one sees vast potential for a novelist.')

The publisher's note (Prakāśakīya, signed by Jay Prakash Mandal, Coordinator, Aaphanta Nepal) situates Jiddī within Aaphanta Nepal's mission of Maithili language revitalisation in Nepal, noting that Jha's previous collections Chiṛai and Reporter Diary are already well-circulated and that Jiddī arrives as his 'third collection in three months within the same year' — an extraordinary rate of production that signals both creative urgency and the maturation of a fully formed literary voice.

### *Formal Analysis and Story Content*

The critical foreword in Jiddī is provided by Dr. Rājendra Vimal, who describes Jha's method as beginning from 'sāmānya ghaṭanāsabhak śṛṅkhalāra' (a chain of ordinary events) and moving through the middle to arrive at a 'karaṇṭ' (current or shock) — a Maithili critical metaphor for the structural technique Western narratology calls 'peripeteia' (sudden reversal) or the Chekhovian 'loaded gun' principle. The title word 'Jiddī' (stubborn/obstinate) is not merely a character trait but a philosophical-ethical position: the stories collectively argue that stubborn insistence on dignity, love, truth, and justice is not a personal flaw but

a social necessity. In Navya Nyāya terms: jiddī (stubbornness) is the sādhya (what is to be established) toward which the narrative liṅga (signs and events) converges.

The urban Kathmandu-Janakpur social panorama — the 'mahānagaronmukh śaharaka parivesh' (urban-oriented city environment) — is the dominant setting of Jiddī. Jha's stories here move more decisively into contemporary Terai urban experience: the crowded media office, the hospital's emergency ward at night, the election-time political tensions, the wedding hall. This urban topography is mapped with a journalist's eye for telling detail and a fiction-writer's capacity for interiority.

## 4.3 Bulbul (बुलबुल) — Short Stories

### *Bibliographic Details*

Title: Bulbul (Nightingale/Bulbul bird). Genre: Maithilī Kathā Saṃgraha. Publisher: Āphanta Nepal, Janakpurdham. First edition: VS 2063 (c. 2006 CE). Copies: 1,000. Copyright: Author. Price: ₹200. ISBN: 978-9937-0129-9-7. Printer: Hāṃs Aphasèṭ Prinṭarsa, Jamal, Kathmandu. Pages: 74.

The dedication reads: 'To Gurubday B.M. Khanal and Brij Kumar Yadav, who showed the path of journalism — with reverence.' This dedication to journalistic mentors places Bulbul at the origin point of Jha's literary career: it is his earliest published collection (VS 2063, some six years before Chiṛai), and it reveals the formative role that journalistic mentorship played in his development as a writer.

Bulbul is the foundational text of Jha's oeuvre, establishing the thematic and formal vocabulary that all subsequent collections develop. The title — bulbul, the beloved songbird of Indo-Persian poetic tradition — signals both the lyrical aspiration of the work and its specific Maithili cultural embedding: the bulbul is the bird of the garden, of love, of the poet's voice. That Jha's debut collection is named for this bird suggests a self-positioning within the lyric-social tradition of Maithili literature, from Vidyapati's bird-imagery through the modern period.

### *Critical Assessment*

Reading Bulbul against Chiṛai and Jiddī reveals a clear developmental arc: the earlier collection is more lyrical, more exploratory, occasionally more emotionally unguarded; the later collections show a tighter formal control, a

more precise social analysis. This is the classic arc of a maturing literary voice, and it is precisely documented across Jha's eight texts. In rasa theory terms: Bulbul is dominated by śṛṅgāra rasa of the saṃbhoga (joy of union) mode; Chiṛai introduces more karuṇa; Jiddī deepens the vīra (heroic resistance to social injustice); and by Khajurībālī, all three rasas are simultaneously active.

## 4.4 Gandha (गन्ध) — Short Stories

### *Bibliographic Details and Content*

Title: Gandha (Smell / Fragrance / Odour). Genre: Kathā Saṃgraha. Publisher: Shrī Rāmānanda Yuvā Club, Janakpurdham. Pages: 122 (the largest of the story collections). The title is stark and sensory: gandha in Maithili carries the full ambiguity of English 'smell' — both the pleasant fragrance (sugandha) and the offensive odour (durgandha) — making it a perfect title for a collection that inhabits the ambiguous zone between attraction and repulsion, between desire and its social coding as contamination.

The critical essay by Dr. Revatī Ramaṇ Lāl ('Sujītak kathā saṃgraha Gandhak prasaṅg ek vimarśa') confirms that Gandha contains twelve stories and that 'most stories are women-centred, based on love and desire.' Lāl's critical intervention notes the influence of the Urdu-Hindi writer Manṭo on Jha's gandha-centred aesthetic: Manto's capacity to write about the body's social coding — its smells, its sexuality, its social shame — without moralising, and to let the reader hold both the seduction and the social critique simultaneously. This is a significant intertextual connection that the Parallel History Framework's śabda-pramāṇa validates.

Applying dhvani theory: the twelve stories in Gandha deploy smell as a sustained metaphor throughout — a figure for memory (Proust's madeleine moment has its Maithili counterpart here), for social othering (the caste-smell that marks bodies as untouchable), for erotic desire (the fragrance of the beloved's hair that becomes a metonymic figure for the entire body), and for moral corruption (the stench of political hypocrisy). This olfactory architecture is a sophisticated formal device: it unifies the collection thematically while allowing each story to activate a different semantic register of the same primal sensation.

## 4.5 Khajurībālī (खजुरीबाली) — Short Stories

### *Bibliographic Details*

Title: Khajurībālī (The Date-Palm Girl / Of the Khajuri Palm). Genre: Kathā Saṃgraha. Publisher: Jay Mangala Devi Prakashan Griha, Janakpurdham. Pages: 136 (the most substantial of the story collections). The title is a piece of pure vakrokti: khajurī (the date palm) is simultaneously a village landscape element, a metaphor for tall graceful femininity, and — through the bālī (the woman, also: the earring, the harvest's bounty) — a condensed image of female dignity, rootedness, and fecundity resisting the arid social landscape around her.

The prefatory material includes a sustained critical introduction that identifies thirteen stories in the collection: 'Dhūnik bhītar' (Inside the Smoke), 'Choṭasan bāt' (A Small Matter), 'Rekhāk pār' (Beyond the Line), 'Prasannatāk lenaden' (Transactions of Happiness), 'Bābūjī' (Father), 'Saṃsārak rīt' (Custom of the World), 'Gāma ghūrlāpar' (Going Around the Village), 'Sambandha nadī' (River of Relationship), 'Paścātāpak bāṭ' (Road of Repentance), 'Ek kap cāha' (One Cup of Tea), 'Khajurībālī,' 'Sukhak sansār' (World of Happiness), 'Aspatalek benchpar' (On the Hospital Bench).

The prefatory writer (from context, a fellow journalist and literary companion of Jha) describes how Jha brought the manuscript in a plastic bag and asked the prefacer to write a foreword, revealing the informal, community-based literary circulation that characterises the Parallel Tradition. The thirteen stories are summarised in the introduction: 'Dhūnik bhītar' traces two brothers' economic and psychological divergence in a materialist age; 'Choṭasan bāt' captures the moment of a son's departure abroad and the parents' heartbreak; 'Rekhāk pār' (Beyond the Line) explores the attraction between an urban woman and a village youth, 'the pure attachment and fascination between them' across the social dividing line; and each subsequent story adds a different facet of contemporary Terai social life.

### *Formal and Thematic Analysis*

Khajurībālī represents the most formally mature of Jha's adult collections. The critical note identifies the collection's governing principle as the documentation of 'madhyam varg' (middle class) and 'nimna madhyam varg' (lower-middle class) consciousness in an era of 'bhautikavādī sabhyatā' (materialist civilisation). This is a precise sociological articulation: the stories inhabit the anxious economic stratum between rural poverty and urban aspiration, a stratum whose specific tensions — the son who must go abroad to remit money,

the daughter whose marriage is a financial transaction, the father whose dignity is eroded by economic dependence — are the defining social experience of the Nepal Terai in the 21st century.

Applying postcolonial theory: the collection's consistent focus on the middle-class Madheshi experience represents an implicit critique of both the Kathmandu-centric Nepali state (which has historically marginalised Madhesh economically and politically) and the India-centric Maithili establishment (which has ignored Nepal-side writers). Jha's stories document the consequences of these dual marginalisations on individual lives: in 'Choṭasan bāt', the emigration of young men is not a personal adventure but a forced response to economic exclusion; in 'Gāma ghūrlāpar', the village-to-city transition is not rural backwardness but a structured dispossession.

## 4.6 Koilī Ghūri Āu (कोइली घूरि आउ) — Children's Stories

### *Bibliographic Details*

Title: Koilī Ghūri Āu (The Cuckoo — Come Back / Return, Cuckoo). Subtitle: Child Stories Collection. Publisher: Āphanta Nepal. First edition: VS 2069 (c. 2012 CE). Copies: 1,100. Price: ₹200. Cover design: Kelaas Daas. ISBN: 978-9937-2-5872-2. Printer: Hāṃs Aphasèṭ Prinṭarsa, Jamal, Kathmandu. Pages: 50. English subtitle on copyright page: 'Koilee Ghuir aau — Child Stories Collection by Sujeet Kumar Jha.'

The title is a direct apostrophe — 'Return, Cuckoo!' — addressed to the koel/cuckoo, the most beloved of Mithilā's birds and a central figure in its lyric tradition from Vidyapati onward. The koel's call in classical Maithili poetry signals spring, longing, the beloved's return, and poetic inspiration itself. In Jha's children's collection, the injunction 'return' carries a double meaning: the natural return of the migrant bird in the spring season, and the cultural return — the summons back — to Maithili language, landscape, and identity that the collection as a whole enacts for its young readers.

### *Critical Assessment: Children's Literature and Cultural Transmission*

Koilī Ghūri Āu occupies a distinctive position in Jha's oeuvre and in the Maithili parallel tradition: it is an act of cultural transmission as much as literary creation. In the Videha Parallel History's terms, children's literature in Maithili is a form of language maintenance — the mechanism through which Maithili reproduces itself across generations in contexts where the language faces pressure from Nepali, Hindi, and English. Jha's choice to write children's

stories alongside his adult fiction signals a commitment to the entire ecological chain of literary culture: from the youngest reader encountering Mithilā's natural world through tales of cuckoos and rivers, to the adult reader confronting its social contradictions through the complex stories of Khajurībālī.

Applying Nikolajeva's framework: the stories' child protagonists are agents of ecological and cultural wisdom, counterposing an innocent, direct relationship with nature against the adult world's complications. This structural inversion — where the child sees clearly what the adult cannot — is a classic device of children's literature (from Andersen through Kipling) and takes on additional resonance in the Maithili context: the child reader is being invited to perceive the natural and cultural inheritance that adult social life has obscured.

## 4.7 Reporter Diary (रिपोर्टर डायरी) — Memoir-Essays

### *Bibliographic Details and Content*

Title: Reporter Diary. Genre: Saṃsmaraṇa Saṃgraha (memoir/recollection collection). Pages: 97. The back cover identifies Jha as the journalist who has 'alaṃga pahacāna sthāpit karavāk' (established a distinctive identity) in Nepali journalism while simultaneously writing Maithili literature without stopping — noting as evidence that within three months of Chiṛai he produced two more books (Reporter Diary and Jiddī).

The table of contents reveals 35+ essay-sketches including political journalism ('Hāt cārṭ-cārṭa kaṣ netājī svādad rahi' — politicians have their own taste in hand-shaking), social commentary ('Vivāha kārdme Maithilī bhāṣā' — Maithili language on the wedding card, an essay on the linguistic politics of matrimonial culture), cultural criticism ('Parivartanak anubhūt daich jayanagar' — experiencing transformation at Jayanagar, the India-Nepal border), urban satire ('Machāna jī sagak ḍinar' — dinner with mosquitoes), medical journalism ('Aspatalek imarjenṣī vārdme ek rāt' — a night in the hospital emergency ward), environmental writing ('Ṭūṣṭakoṣa nāhi calavāyakemkusame khāyal gel chhaik kī?' — What happened to the trustee's bowl?), and electoral commentary ('Canavāk nāmapar paisāk bahas' — the money debate in the name of election).

### *Critical Analysis: The Genre of Reporter Diary*

Reporter Diary occupies a generically hybrid position in Maithili literature: it is simultaneously memoir, social essay, political commentary, and literary journalism. This genre — sometimes called 'lalita nibandha' (light/lyric essay) in the Hindi tradition — has a distinguished lineage in both Hindi (Hazari

Prasad Dwivedi, Ram Vilas Sharma) and Maithili (Harimohan Jha's satirical prose). Jha's Reporter Diary is closest to the subgenre of journalistic memoir exemplified internationally by George Orwell's Essays and domestically by Phanishwar Nath 'Renu's' reportage from the Bihar famine regions.

The essay 'Vivāha kārdme Maithilī bhāṣā' is particularly significant for the Parallel History Framework: it documents the daily linguistic activism of insisting that wedding cards — that most public of social documents, the matrimonial advertisement — be printed in Maithili rather than Hindi or English. This is the ordinary linguistic politics of the parallel tradition: not the grand gesture of literary awards but the daily insistence on the language's dignity in the most intimate social rituals. Applying Navya Nyāya: Jha's inference (anumāna) moves from the liṅga (wedding cards printed in Hindi) to the sādhya (cultural devaluation of Maithili in Madhesh social practice) through the vyāpti (wherever the wedding card language is not Maithili, there the speaker's identification with Maithili culture is weakened).

## 4.8 Doodhmati Weekly — Feature Journalism

***Bibliographic Details***

Title: Doodhmati Sāptāhik (Doodhmati Weekly). Ank 41 (Issue 41), VS 2072 Chaitra 2 (15 March 2016). Published in both Maithili and Nepali. Price: ₹5. This issue includes a front-page story by Jha on the Janakpur civic development project (the Telaha Maṛhā lake beautification — a proposed three-crore-rupee project), coverage of the Nepal Patrakar Mahāsangh's district meeting on the 'Mithila bomb blast', and a political feature on local elections. The newspaper serves as both a primary document of Jha's journalism and a window into the political and social landscape — the civic, environmental, and political life of Janakpurdham — that feeds his fiction.

The newspaper's bilingual nature (Maithili and Nepali) is itself a political-linguistic statement in Nepal's post-2006 transitional constitutional moment: the Madhesh movement of 2007–08 had demanded official recognition of Terai languages including Maithili, and publications like Doodhmati were part of the cultural infrastructure of that movement. Jha's journalism here is not merely professional but constitutional: it enacts in daily practice the language rights that the Madhesh movement fought to establish.

# PART V: SYNTHETIC ANALYSIS AND CRITICAL ASSESSMENT

## 5.1 The Coherence of Jha's Literary Project

Across the eight texts examined, a single coherent literary project emerges. Jha is a writer of Mithilā's contemporary social life: the women who navigate love, family, and dignity in the Terai's patriarchal social order; the men who are pulled between village loyalty and urban opportunity; the children who inherit a natural and cultural world their parents are in danger of losing; the journalist who bears witness to civic corruption and political theatre; the prose stylist who insists on writing all of this in Maithili, against the pressures of Nepali, Hindi, and English. Every text, every story, every essay is a reaffirmation of the same commitments.

The bird metaphor that recurs across his titles — Chiṛai (birds in general), Bulbul (the nightingale), Koilī Ghūri Āu (the cuckoo returns) — is not accidental but constitutive. In Maithili literary tradition, the bird is the poet's voice, the migrant's longing, the natural world's claim on the social world. Jha's birds are never merely decorative: they are figures of cultural persistence, of the Mithilā landscape's enduring claim on its people no matter how far the economic migration has taken them.

## 5.2 Jha and the Parallel Tradition: A Final Assessment

In the terms of the Videha Parallel History Framework, Sujit Kumar Jha occupies a specific and important position. He is: (i) a Nepal-side Maithili author, writing from the geographic and political margin of the Maithili world; (ii) a journalist-writer in the tradition of the parallel tradition's 'witnesses' — Faturilal, Harimohan Jha, Rajkamal Chaudhary; (iii) a women-centred writer, giving sustained narrative attention to female experience in patriarchal social structures; (iv) a children's writer who performs the cultural transmission function essential to the language's survival; (v) an essayist whose political journalism documents the daily lives that official literary culture ignores.

The Nepal Bidyapati Maithili Research Prize he received from the Nepal government is the institutional recognition of this work — but it is institutional recognition of a fundamentally parallel-tradition kind: a state prize from Nepal, not from India's Sahitya Akademi; from the Bidyapati Fund in Janakpurdham, not from the Darbhanga-Patna axis. The geography of the award matters: it

confirms that Jha's significance is specifically Nepal-Maithili, specifically Terai, specifically Janakpurdham.

### 5.3 The Navya Nyāya Synthesis

Applying Gaṅgeśa's fourfold epistemological scheme to the complete assessment of Jha's work: Pratyakṣa — direct reading of the primary texts reveals a writer of consistent formal accomplishment, social commitment, and emotional depth. Anumāna — inference from these textual facts supports the conclusion that Jha is the most significant fiction writer of the contemporary Nepal-side Maithili parallel tradition. Upamāna — comparison with the Maithili tradition (Harimohan Jha, Rajkamal Chaudhary, Dr. Dhīrendra) confirms his distinctiveness: he is the first Nepal-Terai Maithili writer to produce simultaneously across five sub-genres (adult fiction, children's fiction, journalistic memoir, newspaper essay, and laprek) at a level of consistent quality. Śabda — the testimony of critics (Chandresh, Dr. Rājendra Vimal, Dr. Revatī Ramaṇ Lāl, Dharmendr Jhā, Dr. Vijay Kumar Singh, Ayodhyānāth Chaudhary), of the award bodies (Nepal Bidyapati Fund), and of the Videha Parallel History Framework all converge to validate this assessment.

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## APPENDIX: METHODOLOGICAL NOTE

The Nepal Bikram Samvat years cited have been converted to approximate CE years using the standard offset of BS minus 56–57 years. Web sources

consulted include the Videha digital archive (videha.co.in), The Rising Nepal Daily's online archive, the IJCRT (International Journal of Creative Research Thoughts) database, and Wikipedia. All URLs were last accessed April 2026.

**LESSON 088 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**

# Ever New Sushil

WHAT THE CANON LEFT OUT

A Parallel History of Mithila & Maithili Literature

Gajendra Thakur

# EVER NEW SUSHIL

Nita Naval Sushil

Chapter 0

Nita Naval Sushil (Introduction)

Pūrvapaksha (The Preliminary View)

Chapter 1

Pseudocriticism in Maithili (1-3)

Chapter 2

Gharāṛī (Novel) (1973)

Chapter 3

Gāmbālī (Novel) (1982)

Chapter 4

Bhāmatī (Drama) (2013)

Chapter 5

Asmitā (Short Story Collection) (2016)

Uttarapaksha (The Subsequent View)

Chapter 1

Theory

Chapter 2

Post-Theory

Gajendra Thakur Videha edits this magazine <http://www.videha.co.in/> ISSN 2229-547X and currently lives in Delhi.

Chapter 0

Nita Naval Sushil (Introduction)

[Image: A person wearing glasses and a white shirt]

Sushil Chandra Jha, famously known as Sushil

Village + Post- Dulaha, District- Madhubani (Bihar, India).

Birth- January 6, 1942

Mother- Late. Godavari Devi.

Father- Late. Sachchidananda Jha.

Livelihood- Worked at the Budge Budge branch of Sahu Jain Company Limited, Kolkata until 2004.

Activities: Participated in a protest in December 1980, under the aegis of the 'Maithili Mukti Morcha', against the Bihar government's decision to make Urdu the second official language in 1980.

Current Address- Government Colony Block O, Plot-3, Subhash Udyaan Mor, Budge Budge, Kolkata- 700137 (India).

Sushil's Literary World: His literary works include- Gharāṛī (novel) (1973), Gāmbālī (novel) (1982), Bhāmatī (drama) (first staging 1991, publication 2013) and Asmitā (short story collection) (2016). With his permission, all four books are available in the Videha Petar at the link www.videha.co.in/pothi.htm.

Pūrvapaksha (The Preliminary View)

Chapter 1

Pseudocriticism in Maithili (1-3)

I have written in detail about how Ramanath Jha and Udayanath Jha "Ashok" committed "honor killing" on Gangesh, the author of the Tattvachintamani, in my book "Maithili Samikshashastra Part-2". However, such acts did not succeed; this work continues even today, changing forms. This chapter will help in understanding how Sushil was suppressed.

1

Kamalanand Jha writes in "Maithili Upanyas: Samay Samaj A Sawal" (2021)- "After nearly a hundred years of the Maithili novel's journey, the credit for writing a dignified novel on the dream, struggle, and irony of inter-caste marriage among Maithils goes to Gaurinath." So, did Kamalanand Jha snatch this credit from Sushil? Is this the pinnacle of the arrogance of his Brahminical upbringing—that we can bestow credit on whomever we want and take it away from whomever we want—or is it proof of his lack of study? Well, let's leave Kamalanand Jha's selfish world and the world of deceit and enter the innocent

world of Sushil's enchanting literature. Welcome to Sushil's literary world. Presented here is Sushil's 'Gāmbālī' (1982), now available in the Videha Archive at the link <http://videha.co.in/pothi.htm>. Even before the novel begins, in the very first line, Sushil writes about 'Gāmbālī': "In support of widow marriage and inter-caste marriage." And the novel begins. Gāmbālī's death and then the commotion—who will perform her last rites? Brahmin society or Yadav society?

Why do I call Kamalanand Jha a pseudocritic? Because he is a pseudocritic. When I raised the question of pseudocriticism in Maithili in issues 362 and 363 of Videha (dated January 15, 2023, and February 01, 2023 respectively), Kamalanand Jha, due to his ignorance or arrogance, did not admit his ignorance. He introduced his pseudocritical nature through the arrogance of his Brahminical upbringing. In his article (calling it a critical article would be inaccurate) "Daag: Sthapit-Bodhme Hilkor" in Samdiya Mithila (issue dated January 4, 2024), he writes under the characteristics of pseudocriticism: "It is not that no novel on inter-caste marriage was written in Maithili before Daag. However, before Daag, I have not come across a novel centered on the marriage of a Brahmin girl with a Chamar Dalit (Chamar community) boy. Writing openly on a subject considered taboo for discussion is an act of extraordinary courage. Author Gaurinath believes that a balanced society can be built through the bond of marriage."

Now, compare this with Kamalanand Jha's statement from 2021:

"After nearly a hundred years of the Maithili novel's journey, the credit for writing a dignified novel on the dream, struggle, and irony of inter-caste marriage among Maithils goes to Gaurinath."

With his statement from 2024:

"It is not that no novel on inter-caste marriage was written in Maithili before Daag. However, before Daag, I have not come across a novel centered on the marriage of a Brahmin girl with a Chamar Dalit (Chamar community) boy."

This falls completely under Kamalanand Jha's Brahminical arrogance. There is a severe lack of honesty in both the 2021 critic and the 2024 critic. This means that if the credit is now for a novel focused on inter-caste marriage, even if a Brahmin girl and a Chamar boy got married in Sushil's novel, would he then acknowledge Sushil? Anyway, in Gāmbālī, the marriage does not actually take place; it is a live-in relationship, that too between a Brahmin woman (married and widowed) and a Yadav boy (unmarried—whether he was married or not is ambiguous—such things happen in youth. Engagements happen there, sometimes they get married somewhere else). That too, in a village, and when Gāmbālī dies, she has a fifteen-year-old son. And Gāmbālī (the novel) was published in 1982. Gharāṛī (the novel) was published in 1973, in which the boy is Brahmin and the girl is from the Mallah community. Here, one also learns about language. Sushil did not unnecessarily use 'ka' and 'ta' even in 1973. In the PDF (available in the Videha Petar), where it appears initially, he has crossed it out with a pen; the later version is correct. In this novel, there is a romantic relationship between a Mallah girl and a Brahmin's son (at the end of the novel, she is proven to be the Brahmin's biological daughter). So, does this prove that someone who is proficient in language can also think ahead, and that their subject matter is also forward-thinking? Both of these works were suppressed in the mainstream. Udaychandra Jha 'Vinod' from Dulaha village, who is mediocre and has a reactionary ideology (his deceit regarding Sharadindu Choudhary and Premlata Mishra 'Prem' is recorded in Videha's Sharadindu Choudhary special issue and Premlata Mishra 'Prem' special issue), was accepted in the mainstream. But Sushil, also from Dulaha village, who is far ahead of him in language, thought, subject matter, and literary standard, and belongs to his caste, was suppressed. Why wouldn't he be rejected in the mainstream? The pseudocritics either haven't even heard his name, or they engage in such charades.

As for the discussion on inter-caste marriage in Mithila not happening, as Kamalanand Jha says: "Writing openly on a subject considered taboo for discussion is an act of extraordinary courage."

The Dushan Panji is filled with such details. But what Ramanath Jha and Udayanath Jha "Ashok" did with Gangesh Upadhyay, the same was done with "Sushil" by Kamalanand Jha and other critics.

The Gangesh Upadhyay Context

49.

| 188/2 | Charmakarini | Mandar | Vabhaniyam | Chhadan |
• |
| Tattvachintamani | Chhadan Gangesh | Nāī | Ratnakar's Mother (unknown) | Gangesh |
| Karak Gangesh | | | | | |
| | Vallabha | Bhavāi | Maheshwar | | |
| | | | Jeev | | |

21/10 From Chhadan, Tattvachintamani Karak Jagadguru Gangesh

From Chhadan, Tattvachintamani Karak

Gangesh's Vallabha, a Charmakarini, five years after her father's death. The origin of Tattvachintamani Karak Gangesh was for the lineage of the Charmakarini's intellect.

From Chhadan, Tattvachintamani Karak M.M. Gangesh

"Article on Tattvachintamani Karak M.M. P. Gangesh available from ancient panjis.".

"Origin of Gangesh five years after father's death" written anciently somewhere.

From Devanand Panji 39-2, Chhadan, Jagadguru Guru Gangesh's son, from Vabhaniyam, Jayaditya's son, Sadhukar's wife.

From Devanand Panji 339-3, Jagadguru Gangesh's son Supan, from Dau Bhandarisam, Haraditya Dau. Son Suta, from Gora Jajival, Jeev's wife. This

son, Sandgahi Bhaveshwar. At this place, Supan's brother Harisharma Dari, in some places Jajival village.

From Devanand Panji 30=5, Chhadan, Upayakarak M.M. P. Vardhaman's son, from Khandvala, Vishwanath's son Shivanath's wife Gangesh – M.M. Vardhaman/ Supan/ Harisharma.

There are seven types of panjis: Mula, Shakha, Gotra, Patra, Dushan Uteṛh, and Asvajanya Patra Panji.

Darbhanga ruler Madhav Singh ordered the creation of the Shakha Pranayan book. Before this, the Mula Panji was created uniformly for all. Now, separate Shakha Panjis started being made for the purpose of Soti, Jog, and Panjibaddhak. ('Up-Tip' (Sotipura), Nagaram (Pachhiwari Par), Gotra Panji, Patra Panji—all these are inscribed in this book in Mithilakshar. The Gotra Panji contains all the gotras and their ancient roots. The Patra Panji has been in use for about 500 years. It started including the mention of the original village. The Dushan Panji contains the mention of the so-called degeneration that occurred in the lineage. Its discussion becomes possible much later, so that the concerned lineage can survive its ill effects. The Uteṛh Panji provides knowledge about the cessation of sapinda (relationship within seven generations)—mention of six ancestors is found. The names of women are found in the panjis of only Rasaṛh-Arariya.

Modern Social Life Available in Panji: (Dushan Panji)

The work of annotating and transcribing the ancient panjis was started in the month of Chaitra in the year 2000 CE. The Gotra Panji contains details of middle gotra and roots, the Patra Panji contains knowledge of offspring, and the Dushan Panji contains knowledge of the so-called faults in the lineage. In ancient books, from 450 CE onwards, knowledge related to academic degrees prevalent is found. During the transcription period, it was experienced that the historical understanding of Mithila was of a very high order. The panji books were not started just for the sake of authority, but despite the scarcity faced by the people of Mithila and the crooked gaze of the then rulers, they shed light on the educational status of Mithila, the ability to deliberate on Dharma Shastra,

the competence for literary creation, and the proficiency in arts and crafts. Through the transcription, the contemporary world, which is in the era of globalization, can understand the cultural diversity of Mithila and the nature of its historical understanding—these aspects have been placed on the world stage. No other society in the world has kept such a detailed genealogical record of people spread over such a vast geographical area for more than 1500 years. Even while being poor, the people of Mithila kept collecting their identity, honestly preserving the details of their ancestors' education, so-called degeneration, relationships, artistic sense, and migration—this is amazing.

Whether a Brahmin is a Shrotriya or a so-called Jaivaar, it is not for any special privilege or special bondage. The society and the people of Mithila, adorned with the so-called term 'Jaivār', have been more liberal and adaptable from ancient times compared to other civilizations and cultures of India. There is no permanent religious fanaticism here. The scope for reform has been continuously maintained. Even if an uproar about any kind of caste arose at any time in the past, permanent animosity was not maintained. The biggest events of their respective times become timeless and are forgotten. Proof of this is the appendix of Mithila's panji—the Dushan Panji. An event that once destabilized (a burning question) fades from society and the mind after a short time.

Pali Moolka's Devasharma's son Kanhamak's marriage, Budhwal Moolka's Govind's son Damuk's marriage, Sarisab Moolka's Shrinath's son Chakrapani's marriage, Darihara Moolka's Bhim's son Umapati's marriage, Sodarpur Moolka's Shrihari's son Harinath's marriage, Hariam Vasudev's son Krishnadev's marriage, Panichobh Moolka's Madhukar's marriage – with unknown lineage and caste. Sarisav Moolka's Bhavanath's grandson Kamalnayan's son Kishai's marriage – with Valiyas Chamru's son Gangadhar's daughter. Chamru's own marriage was with an unknown girl. Meaning, there is no record of Kishai's mother-in-law's lineage. Kishai's descendants are spread across many villages of Mithila. However, today, society has appropriately forgotten this fact. There are many such instances – e.g., Budhwal Moolka's Madhav's granddaughter Bhim's daughter's marriage, through which many families are spread. Satalakha Ramnath's son Jagannath's mother's side (ghusaut), Udhoran's son Ratnu's mother's side (matrik), Pali Horai's son Ram's mother's side (matrik), Sakarāḍhi Moolka's Beni's son Radhav's mother's side (matrik), Sodarpur Moolka's Pankhu's son Chand's mother's side (matrik), Alay Moolka's Dinkar's son Harikar's mother's side (matrik), Tilay Moolka's

Shripati's son Viduk's mother's side (matrik), etc. These are considered to be of the devadasi tradition, but their descendants are respected in society today. Such examples are abundant in the panji, which have become timeless and do not affect any lineage negatively. Instead, they provide guidance for making decisions in such situations.

More examples: Below Table (1-97), a detailed explanation of some examples from these is given.

1.

| Sarisav | Valiyas | Sarisav | Sakaradhi | Panichobh | Darihara | Pali | Naraval |

• |

| 178/1 | Chamru | | | | | | |

| | Gangadhar's | | | | | | |

| | Mother's side| | | | | | |

| Bhavanath | Nathu | Gangu | Kanha | Helu | Horai | Chand |

| Kamalnayan Kishai | Unknown | Visho | Goge | Rud | Chand | Ram's Mother's side | Devdhar |

238..05

2.

| Budhwal | Paboli | Satalakha | Jagannath's Mother's side | Ghusaut | Ratnu's Mother's side | Darihara | Pali | Ram's Mother's side | Naraval |

| -

| Jatu | Bhim | Ramnath Udhoran | (Unknown) | Helu | Horai | (Unknown) | Chand |

| Madhav Bhim's daughter | Lakshmi | Jagannath Ratnu Chand | Ram Devdhar |

| 178/2 (Unknown)

3.

| Mandar | Sodarpur | Alay | Mandar | Suragan | Pachhi | Pakaliya | Simbhunam |
|

| Ratipati Chandrapti | Deve | Ratnadhar | Lagai | Vanshadhar | Kanha | Jayapati | Duve |

| Godhi's daughter | Pankhu | Bhavadatta | Narasimha  Supe  Ram |

| (Low lineage)71/1

4.

| Sodpur | Valiyas | Gangadhar's Mother's side | Sarisav | Sakaradhi | Panichobh | Darihara | Pali | Ram's Mother's side | Naraval |

| -

| 177/2 | Bhamru | Inter-caste | Nathu | Gange | Kanha | Helu | Helu  Chand |

| Matikar

5.

| Sarisav 186 Karamha | Sakaradhi | Raghav's Mother's side | Sodarpur | Alay | Mandar | Suragan | Pachhi | Pakaliya | Simbhunam |

| |

| None | Narhari | Beni | (Unknown) | Deve | Ratnadhar | Lagai | Vanshidhar | Kanha | Jayapati | Duve |

| Shrinath | Mati | Raghav  Pankhu | Bhavadatta | Narasimha  Supe  Ram |

| Chakrapani

6.

| Paboli Bhanudat | Ekahara | Jagati | Sodarpur | Chand's Mother's side | Alay | Mandar | Suragan | Pachhi | Pakaliya | Simbhunam |

| |

| Sudhapati | Surapati | None | Pankhu | (Unknown) | Ratnadhar | Lagai | Vanshidhar | Kanha | Jayapati | Duve |

| Keshav's daughter | Lakshminath | Hore | Chand  Bhavadatta | Narasimha Supe  Ram |

| 196/7

7.

| Sodarpur | Karamha | Mandar | Alay | Harikar's Mother's side | Darihara | Nima | Suiri | Gadha |

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| Gadadhar | Ramnath | Keshav | Dinkar | (Unknown) | Narasimha | Damodar | Parashuram | Arvind |

| Visho | Mahesh | Jatu | Harikar  Keshav | Ravisharma | Gauri | Nidhi |

| Kumar's daughter |

| 184/2 |

8.

| Hariam | Udanpur | Mandar | Pachhi | Karhi | Rauḍh | Lahanda |

| | --

| Gangu | Damu | Sursar | Sthiti | Aditu | Shukla Viso | Budhai |

| Keshav | Pagu | Hari | Sahib | Sathu |

| Damu's daughter |

| Inter-caste |

9.

| Kochraj Wife | Khandvala | Khauāla | Fanandah | Valiyas | Baherāḍi | Mandar |

|

| Sohago | Surapati | Kone | Harinath | Vibhakara | Varaha | Sagar |

| 208/1 |

Duve | None | Ravinath | Gunakar | Gunakar | Sthiti |

Chandrapti's daughter

Kochraj Wife

10.

| Paboli | Ghusaut | Darihara | Dharuk's Mother's side | Vaherāḍi | Mandar |

| |

| Shivatat | Amru | Nandan | (Unknown) | Angu | Sagar |

| Rupadat | Jivai | Dharu Rud | Sthiti |

| 208/2

| Vasudev's daughter

11.

| Paboli | Ekahara | Jagati | Sodarpur | Pali | Satalakha | Gangoli | Dagar's Mata | Nadam | Yavani |

| |

| Bhanudatta | Surapati | None | Pankhu | Duve | Divakar | Dagar | Yavani | Dhananjay | Daulatijahan |

| Daulatijahan | 43 |

| Sudhapati | Lakshminath | Hore | Chand | Harikar | Gaurishwar | Gangadhar

| Keshav's daughter Harihar

| 196/7

12.

| Kujoli | Khauāla | Mahindravad Pali | Lakhuk's Mother's side | Gangoli | Dagar's Mata | Nadam | Yavani |

|

| Gopal | Govind | Lakhu Yashodhar | Daulatijahan | Dagar | Daulati Jahan | Dhananjay | Daulatijahan |

| 216/1

| Vanshavardhan | Visho | Gangadhar

| Valabhadra's daughter

13.

| Khandvala | Mandar | Pali | Darihara | Baherāḍi | Jamuni | Mandar | Dhareśvar's Mata |

|

| Chand/Chandrapati | Kashi | None | Gune | Gune | Ram | Dhareśvar | (Unknown) |

| Mahesh | Bhim | Batu | Anand | Aphel | Gonu | Madhav Mane

| Gopal

14.

| Goḍhik | Sarisav | Ghusaut | Gangor | Valaha | Madhukar |

|

| Sagar | Gangu | Ratikant | Haru | Sudhakar | Santati |

| Tanaya | Ratnapani | Gunakar | Varadat |

| 216/2

Raghupani's daughter |

(Goḍhi's Mother) |

15.

| Darihara | Sodarpur | Darihara | Ghusaut | Terahuta | Naraval | Rati's Mother |

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| Bhola | Shankar | Khatu | Damodar | Lakhu | Nonai | (Unknown) |

| Mansukh | Gangadhar | Narpati | Hari  Rati

| Yashu's daughter  |

16.

| Sodarpur | Khauāla | Sodarpur | Darihara | Panichobh | Chando | Tilay | Khauāla | Sodarpur |

| Raghav | Purkhu | Nagu | Dharu | Ratan | Kameshvar | Shripati | None | Haridatta |

| Ratnpati | Harihar's Mother (Devadasi) | Duve | Ram | Ramakar | Madhav | Viduk's Mother (Unknown) | Ḍhoḍhe | Devdas |

| 215/1  |

| Yadunath  |

17. (Known as Devadasi)

| Budhwal | Khauāla | Jalival | Mandar | Kurahni | Tilay Shripati | Khauāla | Sodarpur |

•

| Chand | Giru | Jeev | Devaditya | Guneshvar | Vidyapati's Mother (Devadasi) | None | Haridatta |

| 215/2

| Bhanu | Harkhu | Theg | Nathu  | Ḍhoḍhe

| Sudhapati

18. (Known as Devadasi)

| Sodarpur | Pali | Suragan | Darihara | Jeev's Mother | Tilay-Shripati | Khauāla | Sodarpur |

• -

| Lakhan | Gyan | Ravi | Jeev | Devadasi | Lakhuk's Mother (Devadasi) | Ḍhoḍhe | Hardatta |

| Janardan | Vatu | Vachaspati | Amru |

| 214/1

| Chaturbhuj's daughter

| 102/01

19. (Known as Devadasi)

| Sodarpur | Mandar | Hariam | Mandar | Karamha | Khauāla | Sodarpur |

- 

| Pashupati | Yashodhar | Sonhi | Nandan | Pahakar Jagek's Mother (Devadasi) | Ḍhoḍhe | Hardatta |

| Shrihari | Damu | Devnath | Raghu Haruk's Mother (Unknown)

| 214/2 |

| Harinath |

20.

| Janik | Paboli | Budhwal | Valiyas | Vabhaniyam | Mataun | Rakaval | Tilay-Shripati |

- |

| Devdas | Sabhapati | Paran | Dharu | Hore | Dharmu | Kamdev | Vidyapati's Mother (Devadasi) |

| 213/1

Gop | Narayan | Shriram's Mother (Devadasi) | Mansukh | Haripati | Udhe Ratipati |

21.

| Janik | Darihara | Paboli | Budhwal | Khauāla | Jalival | Mandar | Kurahni | Tilay- Shripati |

- |

| Devdas | Ramnath | Vidyanath | Manu | Giru | Jeev | Devaditya | Gunishvar | Vidyapati's Mother (Devadasi) |

| 213/2 |

Raghuni | Gunapati | Sudhapati | Harkhu | Thegh | Nathu | Vidyapati

Haridev

47/3

22.

| From Western Region | Mandar | Karamha | Khauāla | Sodarpur | Vabhaniyam | Sakaradhi | Darihara | Yamugam | Purahadī |

- -

| Arrived | Latāu | Raghu | Mitrakar | Shaktu | Gaheshvar | Tuni | Lakshminath | Kirtivas | Matishvar |

| 212/1

Horai | Shiva | Jeev | Udhoran | Hore | Dhritikar

Madhusudan's Daughter (Unknown lineage) |

23.

| From Western Region | Mandar | Khandvala | Darihara | Baherāḍi | Khauāla | Jalay |

| Arrived | Chandrapti | Dinu | Bhave | Varaha | Harihar | Ratidhar |

| 212/2 | Godhi | Gunakar | Medhu | None | Rati | Matikar (Mother Unknown) |

Shiva

24.

| Charmakar | Talhanpur | Takaval | Darihara | Panchobh | Merandi | Brahmpur | Baijuk's Mother |

| Ananda | Gaḍhava | Jeevdhar | Pathak | Jagannath | Parabhu | Baiju | Ananda |

| 211/1

Ravi | Gahay | Hari  Divakar  |

Mitu's daughter  Harihar  |

253/6  |

25.

| Sodarpur | Mandar | Fanadah | Nadam |

| -

| Aphel | Dharu | Haru | Kanha |

| Divakar | Vishwanath's Mother Ananda's daughter | Son | Jayakar's Mother Ananda's daughter |

| Raghu

| 211/11

26.

| Satalakha Buddhikar | Budhwal | Sodarpur | Takaval | Nadam | Satalakha |

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| 209/1 | Govind | Pashupati | Ganpati | Kanh-marriage to Vasāun (Unknown) | Buddhikar |

Raghunandan's Daughter (Unknown lineage) | Harihar | Chand | Harkhu

27.

| Karamha | Sodarpur | Mandar | Gaul Karamha | Valiyas | Monari | Pali | Kurisama | Keutaram Pandoli |

| |

| Govind | Beni | Megh | Lage | Ganpati | Rud | Samtu | Shrikar | Ganpati |

| None | Jagannath | Baman (Mother Unknown) | Shankar | Dinpati Vanshi | Ravi | Chand |

| 209/11 |

| Devnath |

28.

| Vidhava | Sodarpur | Mandar | Gaul | Valiyas | Monari | Pali | Kurisama | Keutaram Pandoli |

| - |

Beni | Megh Baman (Mother Unknown) | Lage | Ganpati | Rud | Samtu | Shrikar | Ganpati Chand |

Jagannath Shankar | Dinpati Vanshi | Ravi

29.

| 207/1 | Khandvala | Budhwal | Budhwal | Mandar | Takaval | Valiyas | Brahmapura | Merandi | Korthua |

- -

| Rajak Dharam | Mahesh Gopal Madhav | Ganpati Gopi | Dhiroo Mother - Rajaki Bhavaninath | Buddhikar Bhavanath | Keshav Ravidatta | Keshav Gopal | Mangu Gangu | Kanha Narasimha | Jadu |

30.

| 207/11 | Hariam | Valiyas | Naraval | Satalakha | Suragan | Triladhi | Dih Darihara |

| |

| Rajak Dharam Maniki | Som | Ram | Parāu | Kanha | Bhagv | Ratnakar | Rudranand |

Vasudev | Govind's Mother (Rajaki) | Udhe | Vibhu's Mother's side (Rajak Tradition) | Raghu Vidyanidhi |

Gyani |

31.

| 179/1 | Sodarpur | Darihara | Pali | Naraval |

Ravinath | Helu | Horai | Chand |

Duve | Chand | Ram's Mother (Unknown) | Devdhar |

Mase

32.

| 179/II | Karamha | Sodarpur | Darihara | Ghusaut | Darihara | Pali |

Bhanu | Vidhupati | Matikar | Dharu | Helu | Horai |

Harkhu | Rameshvar | Sabhapati's Mother (Unknown) | Udhoran | Chand | Ram's Mother |

Raghav

33.

| 180/I | Sodarpur | Takaval | Yamugāgm | Takaval | Suiri | Gadha Pandoli |

Vidu | Bhavdev | Ganpati | Ravisharma | Parashuram | Arvind |

Ohari | Gangadhar's Mother's side (Unknown) | Juḍāun's Mother (Unknown) | Parāu's Mother (Unknown) | Gauri | Nidhi |

Babu | Suyan |

34.

| 180/II | Sodarpur | Mandar | Beluñch | Khauāla | Ghosiyam | Gadha Pandoli | Hāu | Medhakar | Mahidhar | Damodar | Māngani | Arvind | Lakhan | Pitambar | Khakhnu | Rud | Vagek's Mother (Unknown) | Lanhi | Janardan | Chand |

35.

| 181/I | Sodarpur | Satalakha | Vabhaniyam | Mandar | Yamugam | Sakaradhi | Pali | Gadha Pandoli | Gadadhar | Kashi | Surapati | Vishnupati | Raghupati | Chāḍo | Devsharma | Arvind | Dhruvanand | Ramchandra | Mane | Damu | Umapati | Halleshvar | Kanha | Nidhi (Forbidden lineage) |

36.

| 181/2 | Budhwal | Darihara | Pachhi | Koraḍa | Gadha Pandoli | Rati | Sidhu | Ratnakar | Kanha | Arvind (Forbidden lineage) | Govind | Ram | Shiruk's Mother | Gage | Harikar | Damu |

37.

| 182/1 | Sarisav | Karamha | Sakaradhi | Panichobh | Mandar | Yamugam | Nima | Musari | Gadha Pandoli |

Noni | Narhari | Beni | Harikar's Mother (Unknown) | Vagishvar | Raghupati | Takaval | Parashuram | Arvind Nidhi (Forbidden lineage) |

Shrinath | Mati | Raghav | Mahathu | Shiru  Damodar | Gauri

Chakravani  Ravisharma |

38.

| 182/2 | Sodarpur | Mandar | Hariam | Mandar | Budhwal | Mataun | Gadha Pandoli |

Pashupati | Yashodhar | Sonhi | Nandan | Ram | Bhim | Arvind (Forbidden lineage) |

Shrihari | Damu | Devnath | Raghu's Mother (Unknown) | Nathu | Umapati | Nidhi |

Harinath | (Unknown)  Shiru

39.

| 183/1 | Sodarpur | Pali | Mandar | Pachhi | Mandar | Gadha Pandoli |

Basāun | Mahai | Mangu | Ratnakar | Kanha | Arvind |

Umapati | Madhav | Rati | Aphel's Mother (Unknown) | Gange's Mother (Unknown) | Nidhi (Forbidden lineage) |

Banke | (Unknown) | (Unknown) | Harikar |

40.

| 183/2 | Hariam | Darihara | Budhwal | Sakaradhi | Panichobh | Mandar | Yamugam | Nima Takaval | Gadha Pandoli |

- 

Som | Damu | Raghu | Mahai | Madhukar | Vagishvar | Raghupati | Damodar Ravisharma | Arvind |

Vasudev | Krishndash | Madhav | Manishak's Mother's side (Unknown) | Harikar's Mother | Shiru | Nidhi (Forbidden lineage) |

41.

| 184/1 | Hariam | Udanpur | Mandar | Pachhi | Karhi | Rauḍh | Lahanda | Shudi |

Gangu | Damu | Sursar | Sthiti | Aditu | Darihara | Dudhai

Keshav | Pagu | Hari | Saheb | Sanchu | Shukla Visho |

Damu | Inter-caste |

42.

| 184/2 | Sodarpur | Karamha | Mandar | Alay | Darihara | Nima | Saduri | Gadha Pandoli |

Gadadhar | Ramnath | Keshav | Dinkar | Udhoran | Takaval | Parashuram | Arvind |

Narasimha

Visho | Mahesh | Jatu | Harikar's Mother (Unknown) | Keshav | Damodar | Ravi | Nidhi (Forbidden lineage) |

Kumar | (Unknown) Ravisharma |

43.

| 186/1 | Paboli | Ekahara | Jagati | Sodarpur | Alay | Mandar | Suragan | Pachhi | Pakaliya | Simbhunam |

|

Bhanudatta | Surapati | None | Pankhu | Ratnadhar | Lagai | Vanshidhar | Kanha | Jayapati | Duve |

Sudhapati | Lakshminath | Hore | Chand's Mother (Unknown) | Bhavadatta | Narasimha Supe Ram |

Keshav | (Unknown) |

44.

| 186/2 | Sarisav | Karamha | Sakaradhi | Sodarpur | Alay | Mandar | Suragan | Pachhi | Pakaliya | Simbhunam-Karamha |

•

None | Nahari | Beni | Deve | Ratnadhar | Lagai | Vanshidhar | Kanha | Jayapati | Duve |

Shrinath | Mati | Raghav's Mother | Pankhu | Bhavadatta | Narasimha Supe Ram |

Chakrapani

45.

| 187/1 | Sodarpur | Pali | Sodarpur | Khauāla | Paboli | Valiyam | Gangoli | Navaranga (Inter-caste) |

• -

Vasāun | Raghupati | Babu | Raghupati | Supan | Duve | Varadatta | Koyar |

Pashupati | Jashai | Shivak's Mother (Unknown) | Duve | Devdatta | Shakti | Somadatta | Shripati |

Narhari (Unknown) Dahimat Vasudev

46.

| 187/2 | Sodarpur | Hariam | Mandar | Khandvala | Valiyas | Gangoli | Navaranga | Dahibhat |

|

Shankar | Beni | Macho | Shrihari | Duve | Varadatta | Koiyar | Vasudev |

Govind | Juḍāun | Jorak's Mother (Unknown) | Guddharik's Mother (Unknown) | Shakti | Somadat | Shripati

Raghunandan (Unknown) (Unknown)

47.

| 177/1 | Sodarpur | Valiyas | Sarisav | Sakaradhi | Panchobh | Darihara | Sundipar Pali |

| --

Matikar | Bhamru | Nathu | Goge | Kanha | Helu | Helu |

Bhim | Gangadhar's Mother (Unknown) | Visho | Gage | Rud | Chand | Ram's Mother (Unknown) |

Nath | (Unknown) | (Unknown) |

48.

| 188/1 | Tantani | Sodarpur | Sakaradhi | Jalay | Khandvala | Bharathi | Jalay | Khandvala | Bhduāl Pagu |

•

Ājho | Haladhar | Govind | Girapati | Lanhi | Sakaradhi | Jaiyasharma | Nardev | Koiyar Ram |

| Dharu | Kalyanak's Mother (Unknown) | Mannu | Vibhakarak's Mother (Unknown) | Narasimha | Vishnusharma |

| Shrinath's daughter | (Unknown) | Bhaskar

| Marriage in Tatani caste

49.

| 188/2 | Charmakarini | Mandar | Vabhaniyam | Chhadan |

| Tattvachintamani Karak Gangesh | Chhadan Gangesh's | Nāī | Ratnakar's Mother's side (Unknown) | Gangesh |

Vallabha | Bhavāi | Maheshwar

Jeev

50.

| Charmakarini | Sodarpur | Alay | Mandar | Naraun | Panichobh | Khandvala | Dih Darihara | Brahmpur | Korai |

|

| Medha | Shankar | Gadhu | Aphel | Mushe | Vidyapati | Ratnakar | Matikar | Mangu | Mandar |

| 189/1 | Govind | Shrinath | Vasudev | Jadu | Ramapati | Surapati's Mother (Charmakarini) | Gangu-Medha |

Parashuram |

51.

| 189/11 | Sodarpur | Pali | Mandar | Sakauna | Sakaradhi | Khandvala | Dih Darihara | Brahmapura |

Basāun | Mahai [Madhav] | Mangu [Rati] | Badhan [Dube] | Narayankar | Ratnakar | Matikar | Mangu |

Pashupati Ramakar | Surapati's Mother (Unknown) Medha |

Vachaspati

Bhavani's Mother (Charmakarini)

52.

| 190/1 | Sodarpur | Mandar | Kujoli | Tisuri | Khandvala | Pali | Ghosiyam

| |

| Haḍiṇi |

| Rudramati |

Dalu | Giri | Kanha | Khojo | Shivadatta | Matishvar | Jagannath-Rudramati Marriage

Gadhu | Gage | Surapati | Gudi's Mother (Unknown) | Shubhadatta's Mother (Unknown)  Gonga

Visho  | Unknown Haḍi | Unknown

53.

| 190/II | Naraun | Mandar | Jamuni | Tisuri | Dih Khandvala | Navahatha | Dhosiyam |

|

Madhukar | Gahai | Vir | Khānjo | Shivadatta | Matishvar | Jagannath-Rudramati |

Ruchikar | Dinkar  | Shubhadatta's Mother (Unknown)  Gonga |

Tune  |

54.

| 191/I | Khauāla | Vaherāḍi | Mandar | Sakauna | Dighoi | Pali |

•

| Pali | Sadhukar | Gongu | Vibhu | Gopal | Madhav | Rameshvar Marriage |

| Rajeshwar | Shrikar | Ḍhoḍhe | Bhanukar | Gauripati | Jagai | Inter-caste |

| Suta Rajak | Vibhakarasuta

55.

| 191/II | Khauāla | Vahorāḍi | Mandar | Dighoi  |

•

Sadhukar | Gangu | Vibhu's Mother | Sureshvar-Rajak's Daughter (Rajak Marriage) | Rajak Marriage

Shrikar | Ḍhoḍhe | Bhanukar  Haḍini Rudramati's Daughter

56.

| 192/I | Sodarpur | Karamha | Ekahara | Khauāla | Beluñch | Mandar | Kurahni | Pakaliya |

| -

| Lagari | Manidhar | Raghunath | Ram | Jatu | Dinu | Devaditya | Gunishvar | Shrikar |

| Gopai | Ram  Ganpati | Paran | Thegh | Pankhu | Dinu

Vamdev

Gop's daughter Marriage | Harinath

| Naraun | Gaḍh | Naraun | Gorohini |

|

Alay  |

| Son | Rud | Suj | Kulpati |

| Kanha | Sudhakar | Jagannath | Ratu |

57.

| 192/II | Sodarpur | Beluñch | Pali | Gangoli | Alay | Mandar | Gorahni |

|  - -

Kashi | Devnath | Govind | Ram | Yashai | Harisharma | Kulpati |

Guni | Krishna's Mother (Unknown) | Hore | Mahai | Narayan | Deshu | Ratu |

Shankar  |

58.

| 193/I | Hariam | Darihara | Budhwal | Sakarāḍhi | Vaherāḍi | Darihara | Budhwal | Mandar | Gorahini |

--

Som Vasudev Krishnadev | Damu Krishndash | Raghu Madhav | Mahai Bhnesh | Dinu Raghu | Bhim Daku | Ramaditya Jor | Deshu Lanhi-Mother Unknown | Parisara Kulpati Ratu |

59.

| 193/II | Sodarpur | Ghusaut | Mandar | Jalay | Bhareha | Paboli | Mandar | Gorahini |

|

Manidhar | Ratnu | Jeevdhar | Jeev | Vanshidhar | Jeev | Āngani | Parisara |

Ram | Bhavai | Kalyan | Ram | Shiru | Sursar | Hardatta | Kulpati |

Krishnadev | Ratu |

60.

| 194/I | Sodarpur | Mandar | Fanandah | Pakaliya | Alai | Belmohan |

•

| Charmakar Hirua |

Aphel | Dharu | Haru | Nidhi | Suta (Inter-caste) | Paran |

Divakar | Vidyanath (Mother Unknown) | Sone (Mother Unknown) | Giru (From Charmakar Hirua's daughter) |

Raghu's daughter

61.

| 194/II | Khandvala | Tisaut | Pandol | Khajuri | Sakaradhi

| Tailik Devai |

Mahipati | Jiveshvar's Mother (Unknown) | Vasudev | Panichobh | Chand | Tailik Devai Inter-caste |

Kanha Supan | Dhanpati |

Vishnupati | Nand |

62.

| 195/I | Karamoli | Hariamb | Darihara | Fanandah | Karamoli Gangoli | Pande | Pali | Chando | Fanandah | Pandoli Gangoli |

|

| Gangoli Pande Karm | Mandu Gangu Keshav's daughter Married to Mahapatra | Bhavasharma Vardhaman | Bhim Narasimha | Karam Sadhukar | Karam | Pamakar Durgaditya Dharaditya Pande Karm | Suryakar Haraditya | Bhim Narasimha

63.

| 195/II Charmakar Hirua | Budhwal | Sakarāḍi | Pali | Mandar | Punandah | Pakaliya | Alay | Belmohan |

- -

Shiru Manu Narayan | Ratipati Jasāun | Harpati Amru | Dinkar Sudhe | Shankar | Nidhi | E's daughter | Paran Giru-Charmakar Hirua |

Haru

64.

| 196/I | Darihara | Karamha | Paboli | Budhwal | Mandar | Dighoy |

--

| Haḍini Rudramati |

| Rajak Tradition |

Shaktu | Jor | Ruchidatta | Hore | Vibhu's Mother-Bhaskar | Sureshvar-Rajak's Daughter-Marriage Haḍini Rudramati's Daughter Inter-caste |

Jeev | Bhavanath | Gadhu | Udhe's Mother (Unknown) | Ramakar

Ramdev's daughter

65.

| 196/II | Darihara | Pali | Mandar | Dighoi |

| Rajak Tradition |

| Inter-caste | Someshvar | Shridhar | Dube | Sureshvar-Rajak's Daughter (Rajak Marriage) |

Siddheshvar | Ramadatta's Mother (Unknown) | Supe | Rudramati's Daughter |

Supan

66.

| 197/I | Mandar | Pachhi | Paboli | Pakaliya | Tiralathi | Karnaiṭha | Koiyar |

|

| Campo Yavani

Krishnapati | Shankar | Murari | Charudatta | Harikar | Chakreshvar | Shakti's Wife Campo Yavani |

Suryapati | Ganpati | Bage | Gangu | Divakar | Ram

Bhairav |

67.

| 197/II | Sodarpur | Hariam | Udanpur | Jhanjharpur Pakaliya |

|

| Rajak Tradition |

Bhave | Vibhu | Khantu | Mane's Mother (Rajak Tradition) |

Raghupati | Basāun | Pankhu's Mother (Rajak Tradition) | Lakshmidhar |

Ratipati

68.

| 198/I | Budhwal | Paboli | Satalakha | Ghusaut | Terahota | Koiyar | Bhduāl |
|

Jatu | Bhavdev | Ramnath | Dhoran | Shrikar | Lakshmeshvar | Aditya |
Madhav | Lakshmi | Jagannath's Mother | Ratnu | Supe's Mother (Unknown) | Jagannath | Bhavani |
Bhim |

69.

| 198/II | Sodarpur | Karamha | Mandar | Panchobh | Mahua | Bhduāl |
|

Gadadhar | Ramnath | Keshav | Ratinaath | Giripani | Suj |
Visho | Mahesh | Jatu's Mother (Unknown) | Tripure | Ramapani
Kumar

70.

| 199/I | Sodarpur | Satalakha | Vabhaniyam | Mandar | Yamugam | Sakarāḍi | Vaherāḍi | Bhduāl |

Gadadhar | Kashi | Surapati | Vishnukant | Raghupati | Chāḍo's Mother (Unknown) | Som | Harikesh |
Dhruvanand | Ramchandra | Mane | Damu | Umapati Hore
Harikesh | Halleshvar |

71.

| 199/II | Valiyas | Gangoli | Vithuāl | Khauāla | Tiralathi | Bhadvāl |

Raghu | Raghu | Chand | Damodar | Dhaneshvar | Aditya |

Ramnath | Ramdev | Dashrath's Mother (Unknown) | Vasu | Bodh | Manu |

Narhari

72.

| 200/I | Sodarpur | Budhwal | Jagati | Naraun | Bhadvāl |

•

Gadadhar | Dhiru | None | Dalu | Aditya |

Visho | Ramnath | Misru | Ruchi's Mother (Unknown) | Manu |

Bhanu |

73.

| 200/II | Sodarpur | Baherāḍi | Sodarpur | Chakaliya | Darihara | Pali | Paboli |

|

Shrikar | Umapati | Khedu | Ratnadhar | Ratiśvar | Ganpati | Narasimha Chand's Mother (Unknown) |

Raghunath | Paramanand | Lakhu | Harinath | Raghunath's Mother (Unknown) | Rati's Mother (Unknown)

Krishnadev |

74.

| Narbanga Shakha | Mandar | Pali | Khauāla | Paboli | Valiyas | Gangoli | Narbanga | Dahibhat |

| -

| 201/I |

| Yadav Jaisingh |

Shivpati | Murari | Raghupati | Supan | Dube | Varadatta | Nohari | Vasudev |

Yagyapati | Pankhu | Dube | Devdatta | Shakti | Somadatta | Shripati (Unknown Lineage)

Aphel

75.

| 201/II Yadav Rahmu | Khandvala | Darihara | Budhwal | Sodarpur | Darihara | Fanandah | Kujoli | Pakaliya | Alay | Panchobh |

- -- -

M.M. Damodar M.M. Vishwambhar Hrishikesh Wife Yadav | Jeev Ramdev | Moni Ganpati | Bhairav Thakru-Mother Unknown | Supe Ratu | Mahnu Kanha | Vibhu Gune | Bhase Manu | Hire | Haru |

76.

| 202/I | Pandua | Hariam | Mandar | Vaherāḍi | Satalakha | Pachhi | Nichita Alay | Mandar | Jalay | Singhashram |

|

Janu Gopal Yadunath | Nandan Butan-Mother Unknown | Mahesh Raghu | Barah Dinu | Bhase None | Yagyapani Ratipani | Ganeshvar Madhav | Saheb Murari | Kirtidhar Muladhar | Pande Sarve |

77.

| 202/II | Sodarpur | Karamha | Mandar | Alay | Mandar | Jalay | Singhashram |

Gadadhar | Ramnath | Keshav | Dinkar | Surari | Kirtidhar | Pande |

Viso | Mahesh | Jatu | Harikar | Chand's Mother (Unknown) | Muladhar | Sarve |

Kumar |

78.

| 203/11 | Sodarpur | Sakarāḍi | Pali | Mandar | Fanandah | Pakaliya | Alay | Belmohan |

| -- -

Pankhu | Madhav's Mother | Harpati | Dinkar | Sore | Nidhi | E's daughter | Paran |

Purkhu | Yadunath | Amru | Sudhe | Haru | Giru-Marriage with Hirua Charmakarini |

Bhavanand

79.

| 203/1 | Ghusauth | Khauāla | Kujoli | Mataun Darihara | Gaḍh Alay | Dih Darihara |

• |

| Param Brahmin (Mahapatra) |

Keshav | Gauri | Ramadhar | Naru | Jasai | Lakshēshvar |

Ruchi | Madhav | Krishna's Mother (Unknown) | Batu's Mother (Unknown) Hore (Param Brahmin) |

Bhavdev

80.

| 204/1 | Sodarpur | Vaherāḍi | Sodarpur | Chakaliya | Vihara Darihara | Pali | Alay | Dih Darihara |

• |

Shrikar | Umapati | Chhedu | Rupadhar | Rupadhar | Ganpati | Maheshvar | Lakshēshvar |

Raghunath | Paramanand | Lakhu | Harinath | Raghunath's Mother-Unknown | Rati's Mother (Unknown) | Jasai | Hore (Param Brahmin) |

Krishnadev

81.

| 204/II | Budhwal | Mandar | Jalay | Kujoli | Mataun Darihara | Lay | Dih Darihara |

|

Rati | Shrimani | Pagu | Gangu | Naru | Jasai | Lakshēshvar |

Govind | Teki's Mother (Unknown) | Sudhapati | Ramadhar | Batu's Mother (Unknown) Hore (Param Brahmin) |

Vangu |

82.

| 205/I | Khandvala | Karamha | Naraun | Terahota | Kujoli | Maraḍ |

| Gurupatni |

Gyanapati | Gangeshvar | Gaurishvar | Bhavaditya | Shiva | Bhattbhushan-Marriage with Gurupatni |

Surapati | Shridhar | Murari | Raju |

Duve

83.

| 205/II | Budhwal | Khauāla | Belonch | Visphi | Alay | Dih Darihare | Dih Darihara |

| -

Paran | Batu | Raghu | Rupe | Jasai | Lakshēshvar | Lakshēshvar |

Murari | Ratan | Anant | Dhiru's Mother (Unknown) | Raghu's Mother (Unknown) | Hore | Hore (Param Brahmin) |

Anant Gauri |

84.

| 206/I | Sodarpur | Sakarāḍi | Jalay | Kujoli | Mataun Darihara | Alay | Darihara |

| Gangoli Param Brahmin

Pankhu | Madhav's Mother | Sundar | Gangu | Naru | Maheshvar | Lakshēshvar-Marriage with Gangoli Param Brahmin |

Purkhu | Yadunath | Yashodhar | Ramadhar | Batu's Mother (Unknown) | Jasai

Bhavanand |

85.

| 206/II | Sodarpur | Belonch | Pali | Gangoli | Alay | Darihara |

•

Kashi | Devnath | Govind | Ram | Jasai | Lakshēshvar |

Guni | Krishna's Mother (Unknown) | Hore | Mahay | Narayan's Mother (Unknown) | Hore-Marriage with Path Patita Kanya (Fallen woman) |

Shankar

86.

| 216/I Yavani Daulat Jahan's Daughter | Sodarpur | Khauāla | Mahindravara Pali | Gangoli | Khandvala | Mandar | Pali | Darihara | Baherāḍi |

|

Raghupati Ratipati Balabhadra | Govind Viso | Nathu Yashodhar | Dgaru-Mother Unknown Gangadhar | Chandrapti Mahesh Gopal | Kashi Bhim | None Batu | Gune Anandu | Gune Aphel-Marriage with Yavani's daughter |

87.

| Jamuni | Mandar | Chakarahada | Harini Dighoy | Tripure | Goṇḍi |

| -

| Ram | Dhareśvar's Mother (Unknown) | Mane | Dhananjay | Goḍhai | Goṇḍi (Village) |

| Goḍhi | Madhav | Harikanth | Purandar's daughter |

Mane |

88.

| 227 | Mahishi Budhwal | Sodarpur | Valiyas | Karamha | Sakaradhi | Panchobh | Paboli | Pali |

•

Chand | Ruchi | Rud | Dukhan Satar | Harishvar | Vachaspati | Janu | Krishnadev |

Ramchandra | Jayadatta | Harinath Dhane | Mahesh | Dharamu | Mukund |

Garuḍ Ruchinath Gonu Hari

Ramani Ramakrishna

Balgopal

Mahi

89.

| 226/II | Naraun | Pali | Pali | Darihara | Karamha | Ekahara | Mandar | Sodarpur |

• -

Tune | Damu | Dheeru | Gopal | Pashupati | Harkhu | Narhari | Harkhu |

Gonu | Gopi | Shrinath | Ratidev | Dashrath | Gopi | Lakshminath | Jayaram |

Haripani Chiku Ramchandra Abhimanyu

Harinath Paramanand

Pranapati

90.

| 218/I | Karamha | Sarisav | Vabhaniyam | Yamugam | Purahadī |

- -

| Charo Arrived from Western Region

Gangeshvar | Gangu | Govind | Kirtivas | Matishvar |

Ram | Ratnapani | Ainṭho | Nitikar's Mother (Unknown) | Dhritikar |

Harikar |

91.

| 218/II | Sodarpur | Pali | Sodarpur | Darihara | Khandvala | Budhwal | Khauāla | Brahmapura | Purahadī |

| -

Nathu | Narpati | Thegh | Dheeru | Kusum | Vasu | Subhe | Raghunath | Ratu |

Vasudev | Ruchi | Yashodhar | Lakhan | Dhane | Vagu | Pānthu | Mangu

Shripati |

92.

| 219/I | Mahindravara Pali | Gangoli | Darihara | Kerval Pali | Morasand Karamha |

- --

| Kerval Shakha

Bhadu | Gangadhar | Govind | Jayadatta | Brahmeshvar |

Nathu's Mother (Unknown) | Gadadhar | Siru | Gopal | Sthiti |

Yashodhar |

93.

| 219/II | Sodarpur | Darihara | Paboli | Susaila | Darihara |

| | -

Gopinath | Sursar | Harihar | Sure | Lakshēshvar |

Hau | Vir | Shashidhar | Madhav | Hore-Marriage with Gangoli Path Patita Kanya |

Jeev | Kujoli

| Murari

| Jage

94.

| 220/I | Pali | Paboli | Mandar | Pali | Purisama | Pandoli |

| |

| Vartini Vidhava |

Hari Goni | Bage | Sarvay | Samru | Shrikar | Ganpati |

Sudhakar | Duven's Mother (Unknown) | Shrikar | Vanshi | Ravi | Chand-Vidhva's Offspring |

95.

| 220/II | Hariam | Sodarpur | Karamha | Khauāla | Jamuni | Khauāla | Ghosiyam | Suragan | Hoiyar |

•

Narhari Bhave Murari | Ram Bhim | Harikar Mitu | Sudhakar Buddhikar | Deve Maheshvar | Das Shashikar | Vashishtha | Devsharma None | Shivasimha Dham |

96.

| 221/I | Kujoli | Mandar | Naraun | Mandar | Suragan | Nikhuti |

| Dhiwar Dasi |

Jeev | Pritikar | Shashi | Bhavaditya | Narayan | Mandan-Wife Dhiwar Dasi |

Mahay | Shashi | Jeev | Ganpati | Dalu

Gopinath

97.

| 221/II | Mandar | Karamha | Khauāla | Belonch | Pali | Pachhi | Balha |

|

Latāu | Raghu | Mitu | Mitraditya | Madhav | Indra | Khānjo |

Horay | Shiva | Jeev's Mother (Unknown) | Keshu | Gop-Marriage with Dasi | Bhav | Damu |

Madhusudan |

Explanation of Example 1 from Table (1-97): Gunvati Himsha, who belonged to another caste, was married to Chamru of the Valiyas lineage. They had a son, Gangadhar. Their descendant (daughter) was married to Nathu of the Sarisav lineage – their son was Visho. Then Visho's daughter was married to Gangu of the Sakarāḍhi lineage – their son was Goge. Goge's daughter was married to Kanha of the Panichobh lineage – their son was Rud. Rud's daughter was married to Helu of the Darihara lineage – their son was Chand. Chand's daughter was married to Horai of the Pali lineage – their son was Ram – Ram's mother's side is unknown. Ram's descendant (daughter) was married to Chand of the Naraval lineage. Their son was Devdhar, who became completely pure (in the sixth generation).

Similarly:

| Vaherāḍi's Varaha's son None's marriage | From the western direction |

| Khauāla Harihar's son Rati's marriage | was for the sake of a girl of unknown lineage/social status |

| Mandar lineage's Godhi's son Shiva's marriage | For the offspring of Charmakarini Ananda |

| Khandabala's Dinu's son Gunakar's marriage

| Darihara's Mane's son Megh's marriage | For the offspring of Yavani Daulati Jahan |

| Talhanpur lineage's Ravi's son Milu's marriage | Mandar Maraḍ lineage's Bhatt Bhushan, who married his guru's wife, for his offspring |

| Tankabal's Jeevdhar's son Gahai's marriage

| Darihara Pa. Hari's son Harihar's marriage | For the offspring of the Param Brahmin (Mahapatra's) daughter |

| Panichobh Jagannath's marriage

| Sodarpur Divakar's son Raghu's marriage | For the offspring of the Vartini Vidhava (fallen woman) |

| Nadam's Kanh's marriage

| Sodarpur's Ratipati's son Balabhadra's marriage

| Khauāla Govind's son Visho's marriage

| Khandabala Mahesh's son Gopal's marriage

| Khandabala Surapati's son Duve's marriage

| Karamha Gangeshvar's son Shridhar

| Naraun Gaurishvar's son Murathi

| Sakarāḍhi Bhavaditya's son Ramu

| Kujoli Shiva's marriage

| Budhwal's Paran's grandson Murari's son Anant's marriage

| Khauāla's Badu's son Ratan's marriage

| Beluñch Raghu's son Anant's marriage

| Visphis's Rupe's marriage

| Alay's Jasai's marriage

| Sodarpur Jeev's marriage

| Darihara Sursar's son Vir's marriage

| Mandar's Savai's son Sursar's marriage

| Pali's Samru's son Sursar's marriage

| Kurisama Sakarāḍhi's Shrikar's son Ravi's marriage

| Khandavala Vishwambhar's son Hrishikesh's marriage | Was for the sake of Yadav Rahmu's daughter |

| Daridara Jeev's son Ramdev's marriage

| Budhwal's Mani's son Ganpati's marriage | Was for the sake of Charmakar Hirua's daughter |

| Darihara's Supe's son Ratu's marriage

| Fanandah's Mahnu's son Kanha's marriage | Was for the sake of the Gop's daughter |

| Sodarpur's Purkhu's son Bhavanand's marriage | Was for the sake of the Rajak's daughter Haḍini Rudramati's daughter |

| Sakarāḍhi's Madhav's marriage

| Mandar's Dinkar's son Sudhe's marriage | Was for the sake of Charmakarini Medha's offspring |

| Fanandah's Sore's son Haru's marriage

| Sodarpur Manidhar's grandson Ram's son Vasudev's marriage | Was with the Koch royal family of Assam (king) |

| Karamha Raghunath's son Harinath's marriage | Daughter's name Sohago |

| Ekahara Ram's son Ganpati's marriage

| Khauāla Jadu's son Paran's marriage

| Beluñch's Dinu's son Thegh's marriage

| Beluñch's Dinu's

| Khauāla Shrikar's son Divakar's marriage

| Baherāḍi Gangu's son Dok's marriage

| Sakauna Gopal's son Gauri Patik's marriage

| Didhoy Madhav's son Jagai's marriage

| Chhadan's Tattvachintamani Karak Gangesh's

| Vallabha Charmakarini, five years after her father's death, the origin of Tattvachintamani Karak Gangesh

| Sodarpur Govind's son Parashuram's marriage

| Alay's Gadhu's son Shrinath's marriage

| Mandar's Aphel's son Gadhu's marriage

| Panichobh's Vidyapati's son Ramapati's marriage

| Khandabala's Surapati's son Duve's son Chandrapti's daughter's marriage

[The panjis, I also have around 11,000 palm leaf J.P.G. images on a DVD available separately in my book, and I also distributed that DVD in the 'Sagar Raati Deep Jare' event in Kabipur, but due to the Dushan Panji in it, how many disputes arose, how many people came face-to-face and abused over the phone. Even now, many people seethe internally when it is mentioned and puff and pant in gossip as if they have drunk blood. In this Dushan Panji, there were written records of Brahmins marrying other castes, especially Dalits and Muslims, or marrying after the husband's death. It was not possible for us to tamper with it. The transcription from Mithilakshar to Devanagari has been done verbatim in the panji book. Here I am providing the link to the original palm leaf and basaha leaf written panji (on the Videha Archive at this link http://videha.co.in/pothi.htm). Along with it, the Dushan Panji - original Mithilakshar writing - palm leaf single PDF is also available. No one can say that there is an iota of error here. Gangesh's birth 5 years after his father's death and then his marriage to a Charmakarini is described here. This is Gangesh, the founder of Navya-Nyaya. The marriage with Ananda Charmakarini is also found here, which became the basis of my love story "Shabdashastram" (first published in the "Jakhana Takhan" love story special issue, its English translation by me, "The Science of Words", was published in the Sahitya Akademi, Delhi's magazine Indian Literature, and now both versions are collected in my story collection "Parvat Upar Bhamara Je Sutal").

2

Pseudocriticism in Maithili (Kamalanand Jha Context - 1)

The title of Kamalanand Jha's book "Maithili Upanyas: Samay Samaj A Sawal" (2021) is misleading. It is a collection of his few syndicated so-called critical articles on a few upper-caste novelists. This 263-page book, in hardbound, can only be sold to libraries, where it will rot. I bought this for four hundred and five rupees from Amazon, but there is no content worth five paise in it. There is one correction here, and about the upper-caste writer Subhash Chandra Yadav's novel 'Gulo', without reading it, he wrote two lines and dismissed it. I am presenting those two lines here for your entertainment. You must have read Gulo, if you haven't, read it first, because then the experience will be more entertaining. Gulo is available with Subhash Chandra Yadavji's permission on the Videha Archive at this link http://videha.co.in/pothi.htm.

"The novel's weakness is the author's political bias. Partiality towards a particular politics does not do justice to the work."

In a novel where politics is far away, there is no question of 'political bias' and 'partiality towards a particular politics'. The terms 'political bias' or 'partiality' were used like a comet or a meteor. Subhash Chandra Yadavji's 'Vhot', which came out in 2022 and is available with Subhash Chandra Yadavji's permission on the Videha Archive at this link http://videha.co.in/pothi.htm, is about politics, but even there, there was no need for Subhashji's style of 'political bias' or 'partiality' terms. Read my book 'Nita Naval Subhash Chandra Yadav', available at this link <http://videha.co.in/pothi.htm>.

Kamalanand Jha's Brahminical caste prejudice against Subhash Chandra Yadav without reading him is a warning bell. Just as Kamalanand Jha, while promoting Brahminism, holds the cover of leftism and wants to sacrifice social justice, the parallel stream is aware of this. In his bio-data, he proudly mentions the Sahitya Akademi's Maithili translation assignment, snatching it from a fellow upper-caste person, by suppressing the rights of people from the parallel stream. And this assignment was given to him not on merit but on caste titles, in exchange for these deeds. For people like him, there is a line in the Maithili bio-data; for the parallel stream, it is a matter of life and death.

3

Pseudocriticism in Maithili (Kamalanand Jha Context - 2)

Dinesh Kumar Mishra's 'Dui Patan Ke Beech Mein' is the historical autobiography of the Kosi River. He has also written the historical autobiography of other streams of Mithila, such as Bandini Mahananda, Bagmati Ki Sadgati!, Dui Patan Ke Beech Mein.. (Kosi Nadi Ki Kahani), Na Ghat Na Ghar, Bagawat Par Majboor Mithila Ki Kamla Nadi, Bhutahi Nadi aur Takniki Jhaṛ-Phunk, The Kamla River and People On Collision Course, Bhutahi Balan- Story of a ghost river and engineering witchcraft, Refugees of the Kosi Embankments. Pankaj Jha Parashar, a member of the Sahitya Akademi's Maithili Advisory Committee, had these books translated paragraph

by paragraph into Maithili and published them as his own novel, which the pseudocritic Kamalanand Jha calls the research of this thief writer Pankaj Jha Parashar! To be clear, both this thief writer and the pseudocritic are in the Hindi department of Aligarh Muslim University. This research is by Dinesh Kumar Mishra, who has a B. Tech. in Civil Engineering from IIT Kharagpur in 1968 and an M. Tech. in Structural Engineering in 1970, and is qualified for that research. When enrollment in a subject is not possible, people enroll in Hindi out of desperation, otherwise Kamalanand Jha would have understood that this research could be done by a civil engineer, he might have understood. The Hindi original and Maithili screenshot are attached below.

Dinesh Kumar Mishra is not from Mithila, but he has written the stories of all the streams of Mithila. We are all grateful to him, and the people of Mithila can never repay his debt. But it was proven again that the mainstream, hungry for awards and positions, repays with ingratitude. This author was also 'saved' by Taranand Viyogi about ten-twelve years ago, who used to write that he was influenced by poetry and inadvertently used someone else's content in his own work, and so on. Now he has taken refuge with Kamalanand Jha. But unfortunately! Just as Kamalanand Jha, while promoting Brahminism, holds the cover of leftism and wants to sacrifice social justice, the parallel stream is aware of this. People with land and property became communists to avoid the ceiling, and now Brahminism takes refuge in leftism to survive. Such people have done a lot of damage to communism.

All of Dinesh Kumar Mishra's books are now available with his permission in the Videha Archive:

http://videha.co.in/pothi.htm

Let me add an anecdote here: When Bill Gates was asked if he was bringing the Xbox to India late due to fear of piracy, his answer was that Microsoft has never delayed a product due to fear of piracy. Similarly, in Videha Petar, we will continue to enrich it despite the risk, because the rotten fish in the parallel stream do not spoil all the fish in the pond; the Mallahs keep picking out the rotten fish one by one, they keep picking. This is the final blow to syndicated criticism.

Original Dinesh Kumar Mishra (Dui Patan Ke Beech Mein... 2006): It is noteworthy that between 1923 and 1946, there were 5,10,000 deaths from malaria, 2,10,000 from kala-azar, 60,000 from cholera, and 3,000 from smallpox (total 7,83,000) in the Kosi region.

Thief Pankaj Jha Parashar (Member, Sahitya Akademi's Maithili Advisory Committee) [Jal Prantar 2017 (p. 103)]:

Original Dinesh Kumar Mishra (Dui Patan Ke Beech Mein... 2006): The work of damming the Kosi river in Bihar in India was first undertaken in the 12th century by a king named Lakshmana II. For this work, he received the title of 'Bir' from his subjects, and the embankment came to be known as 'Birbandh'. Remains of this embankment are still visible about 5 kilometers south of Bhimangar in Supaul district. Dr. Francis Buchanan (1810-11) estimated that this dam might have been an outer wall for the security of some fort, as it extended for 32 kilometers along the western bank of the Dhaus river from Tiljuga to its confluence. Dr. W.W. Hunter (1877) disagreed with Buchanan's argument that this dam was a fort's defense wall. Citing local people, Hunter believed that most people did not consider it a fort wall, and according to them, it was something else, but he was not in a position to say definitively. Nevertheless, the common belief is that it was an embankment built along the Kosi river to prevent the river's flow from shifting westward. People also said that it seemed the construction of this embankment might have been stopped abruptly.

See how the pseudocritic Kamalanand Jha supports the thief novelist. Excerpt from pseudocritic Kamalanand Jha quoting thief Pankaj Jha Parashar (Maithili Upanyas, Samay, Samaj A Sawal p. 257-258):

Thief Pankaj Jha Parashar (Member, Sahitya Akademi's Maithili Advisory Committee) [Jalprantar 2017 (p. 31)]:

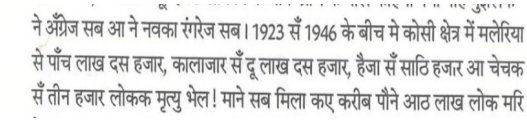
Original Dinesh Kumar Mishra (Dui Patan Ke Beech Mein... 2006): A glimpse of the ferocity of the Kosi's flow is seen when Firoz Shah Tughlaq's army was returning from Bengal to Delhi in 1354 AD. It is said that when the Sultan's armies reached the banks of the Kosi, they saw the armies of Haji Shamsuddin Ilyas, who had founded Hajipur and Samastipur, standing ready for battle on the other side. Firoz's armies stood pondering on the banks of the Kosi somewhere near Kursela. The river's speed prevented them from advancing. Finally, it was decided to move north along the river and find a suitable crossing point. The Sultan's armies went almost a hundred kos upstream and crossed the river near

Jiyaran, located where the river descends from the mountains to the plains. Here, the river's course was narrower, but the current was so swift that heavy stones weighing five hundred maunds were carried away like straw. Where crossing seemed possible, the Sultan placed rows of elephants on both sides, with ropes hanging from the downstream row so that if anyone was swept away, they could be rescued with these ropes. Shamsuddin had never imagined that the Sultan's armies would cross the Kosi, and when he learned that they had succeeded in crossing, he fled.

Thief Pankaj Jha Parashar (Member, Sahitya Akademi's Maithili Advisory Committee) [Jalprantar 2017 (p. 105)]:

[मूल दिनेश कुमार मिश्र (दुइ पाटन के बीच में... २००६): यह ध्यान देने की बात है कि 1923 से 1946 के बीच कोसी क्षेत्र में मलेरिया से 5,10,000, कालाजार से 2,10,000, हैजे से 60,000 तथा चेचक से 3,000 मौतें (कुल 7,83,000) हुईं।

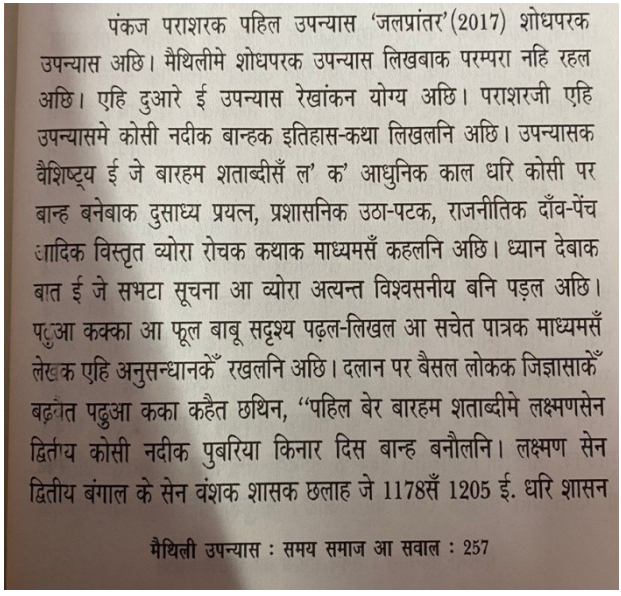
चोर पंकज झा पराशर (साहित्य अकादेमीक मैथिली परामर्शदात्री समितिक सदस्य) [जलप्रांतर २०१७ (पृ. १०३)]:


ने अँग्रेज सब आ ने नवका रंगरेज सब। 1923 सँ 1946 के बीच मे कोसी क्षेत्र में मलेरिया
से पाँच लाख दस हजार, कालाजार सँ दू लाख दस हजार, हैजा सँ साठि हजार आ चेचक
सँ तीन हजार लोकक मृत्यु भेल! माने सब मिला कए करीब पौने आठ लाख लोक मरि

मूल दिनेश कुमार मिश्र (दुइ पाटन के बीच में... २००६): भारतवर्ष में बिहार में कोसी नदी को बांधने का काम 12वीं शताब्दी में किसी राजा लक्ष्मण द्वितीय ने करवाया था और इस काम के लिए उसने प्रजा से 'बीर' की उपाधि पाई और नदी का तटबन्ध 'बीर बांध' कहलाया। इस तटबन्ध के अवशेष अभी भी सुपौल जिले में भीम नगर से कोई 5 किलोमीटर दक्षिण में दिखाई पड़ते हैं। डॉ. फ्रांसिस बुकानन (1810-11) का अनुमान था कि यह बांध किसी किले की सुरक्षा के लिए बनी बाहरी दीवार रहा होगा क्योंकि यह बांध धौस नदी के पश्चिमी किनारे पर तिलयुगा से उसके संगम तक 32 किलोमीटर की दूरी में

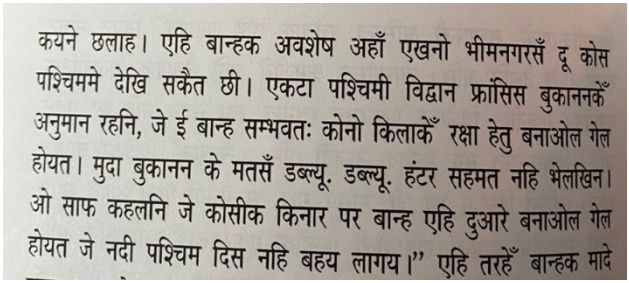
फैला हुआ था। डॉ. डब्लू.डब्लू. हन्टर (1877) बुकानन के इस तर्क के साथ सहमत नहीं थे कि यह बांध किसी किले की सुरक्षा दीवार था। स्थानीय लोगों के हवाले से हन्टर का मानना था कि अधिकांश लोग इसे किले की दीवार नहीं मानते और उनके हिसाब से यह कुछ और ही चीज थी मगर वह निश्चित रूप से कुछ कहने की स्थिति में नहीं थे। फिर भी जो आम धारणा बनती है वह यह है कि यह कोसी नदी के किनारे बना कोई तटबन्ध रहा होगा जिससे नदी की धारा को पश्चिम की ओर खिसकने से रोका जा सके। लोगों का यह भी कहना था कि ऐसा लगता था कि इस तटबन्ध का निर्माण कार्य एकाएक रोक दिया गया होगा।

छद्म समीक्षक कमलानन्द झा द्वारा चोर उपन्यासकारक पीठ ठोकब, देखू छद्म समीक्षक कमलानन्द झा द्वारा उद्धृत चोर पंकज झा पराशर **(**मैथिली उपन्यास, समय, समाज आ सवाल पृ. २५७-२५८**):**



पंकज पराशरक पहिल उपन्यास 'जलप्रांतर'(2017) शोधपरक उपन्यास अछि। मैथिलीमे शोधपरक उपन्यास लिखबाक परम्परा नहि रहल अछि। एहि दुआरे ई उपन्यास रेखांकन योग्य अछि। पराशरजी एहि उपन्यासमे कोसी नदीक बान्हक इतिहास-कथा लिखलनि अछि। उपन्यासक वैशिष्ट्य ई जे बारहम शताब्दीसँ ल' क' आधुनिक काल धरि कोसी पर बान्ह बनेबाक दुसाध्य प्रयत्न, प्रशासनिक उठा-पटक, राजनीतिक दाँव-पेंच आदिक विस्तृत व्योरा रोचक कथाक माध्यमसँ कहलनि अछि। ध्यान देबाक बात ई जे सभटा सूचना आ व्योरा अत्यन्त विश्वसनीय बनि पड़ल अछि। पढ़ुआ कक्का आ फूल बाबू सदृश्य पढ़ल-लिखल आ सचेत पात्रक माध्यमसँ लेखक एहि अनुसन्धानकेँ रखलनि अछि। दलान पर बैसल लोकक जिज्ञासाकेँ बढ़ैत पढ़ुआ कका कहैत छथिन, "पहिल बेर बारहम शताब्दीमे लक्ष्मणसेन द्वितीय कोसी नदीक पुबरिया किनार दिस बान्ह बनौलनि। लक्ष्मण सेन द्वितीय बंगाल के सेन वंशक शासक छलाह जे 1178सँ 1205 ई. धरि शासन

मैथिली उपन्यास : समय समाज आ सवाल : 257



कयने छलाह। एहि बान्हक अवशेष अहाँ एखनो भीमनगरसँ दू कोस पश्चिममे देखि सकैत छी। एकटा पश्चिमी विद्वान फ्रांसिस बुकाननकेँ अनुमान रहनि, जे ई बान्ह सम्भवतः कोनो किलाकेँ रक्षा हेतु बनाओल गेल होयत। मुदा बुकानन के मतसँ डब्ल्यू. डब्ल्यू. हंटर सहमत नहि भेलखिन। ओ साफ कहलनि जे कोसीक किनार पर बान्ह एहि दुआरे बनाओल गेल होयत जे नदी पश्चिम दिस नहि बहय लागय।" एहि तरहेँ बान्हक मादे

चोर पंकज झा पराशर **(**साहित्य अकादेमीक मैथिली परामर्शदात्री समितिक सदस्य**) [**जलप्रांतर २०१७ **(**पृ. ३१**)]:**

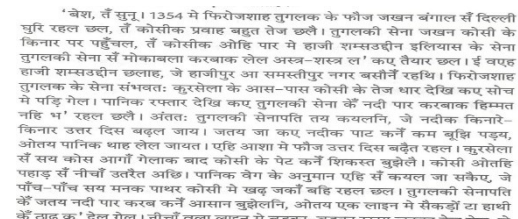
पढ़ुआ कका पछिला गप केँ आगाँ बढ़बैत कहलखिन, 'फूल बाबू, कोसी नदीक बेसिन प्राचीन काल सँ मनुक्खक निवास लेल उपयुक्त स्थान रहल अछि। बारहम-तेरहम सदी मे भारत मे जखन कइक टा नदी सुखा गेल, तँ ओहि ठामक पशुचारक समाजक लोक एतय आबि कए बसलाह। तहिये सँ बढ़ैत जनसंख्या आ कोसी नदीक बदलैत प्रवाहक मध्य टकराहटि होमय लागल। नदीक अनियंत्रित धारा केँ लोक बाढ़ि बूझय लागल। पहिल बेर बारहम शताब्दी मे लक्ष्मणसेन द्वितीय कोसी नदीक पुबरिया किनार दिस बान्ह बनौलनि। लक्ष्मणसेन द्वितीय बंगाल के सेन वंशक शासक छलाह, जे 1178 सँ 1205 ईस्वी धरि शासन कयनेँ छलाह। एहि बान्हक अवशेष अहाँ एखनो भीमनगर सँ दू कोस पश्चिम मे देखि सकैत छी। एकटा पश्चिमी विद्वान फ्रांसिस बुकानन के अनुमान रहनि, जे ई बान्ह संभवत: कोनो किला के रक्षा हेतु बनाओल गेल होयत। मुदा बुकानन के मत सँ डब्लू. डब्लू. हंटर सहमत नहि भेलखिन। ओ साफ कहलखिन, जे कोसीक किनार पर बान्ह एहि दुआरे बनाओल गेल होयत, जे नदी पच्छिम दिस नहि बह' लागय।' पढ़ुआ कका सँ मुँहजबानी एतेक रास ऐतिहासिक तथ्य सुनियो कए फूल बाबू सहमति मे मूड़ी नहि डोलेलखिन। जाहि सँ ओतय बैसल लोक सबहक उत्सुकता और बढ़ि गेलनि, जे गप मे एहेन कोन तथ्य रहि गेलै जे फूल बाबू संतुष्ट नहि भेलखिन? लोक केँ बुझेलनि जे फूल बाबू शास्त्रार्थ के अखड़हा पर माटि फेकि रहल छथिन। पढ़ुआ कका केँ आइ जोड़ीदार भेटि गेलनि!

जलप्रांतर / 31

मूल दिनेश कुमार मिश्र **(**दुइ पाटन के बीच में... २००६**):** कोसी के प्रवाह कि भयावहता की एक झलकफिरोजशाह तुगलक की फौज के सन् 1354 में बंगाल से दिल्ली लौटने के समय मिलती है। बताया जाता है कि जब सुल्तान की फौजें कोसी के किनारे

पहुँचीं तो देखा कि नदी के दूसरे किनारे पर हाजी शम्सुद्दीन इलियास की फौजें मुकाबले के लिए तैयार खड़ी हैं। यह वही हाजी शम्सुद्दीन थे जिन्होंने हाजीपुर तथा समस्तीपुर शहर बसाये थे। फिरोज की फौजें शायद कुरसेला के आस-पास किसी जगह पर कोसी के किनारे सोच में पड़ गईं। नदी की रफ्तार उन्हें आगे बढ़ने से रोक रही थी। आखिरकार फैसला हुआ कि नदी के साथ-साथ उत्तर की ओर बढ़ा जाय और जहाँ नदी पार करने लायक हो जाय वहाँ पानी की थाह ली जाये। सुल्तान की फौजें प्रायः सौ कोस ऊपर गईं और जियारन के पास, जो कि उसी स्थान पर अवस्थित था जहाँ नदी पहाड़ों से मैदानों में उतरती थी, नदी को पार किया। नदी की धारा तो यहाँ पतली जरूर थी पर प्रवाह इतना तेज था कि पाँच-पाँच सौ मन के भारी पत्थर नदी में तिनकों की तरह बह रहे थे। जहाँ नदी को पार करना मुमकिन लगा उसके दोनों ओर सुल्तान ने हाथियों की कतार खड़ी कर दी और नीचे वाली कतार में रस्से लटकाये गये जिससे कि यदि कोई आदमी बहता हुआ हो तो इस रस्सों की मदद से उसे बचाया जा सके। शम्सुद्दीन ने कभी सोचा भी न था कि सुल्तान की फौजें कोसी को पार कर लेंगी और जब उस को इस बात का पता लगा कि सुलतान की फौजों ने कोसी को पार करने में कामयाबी पा ली है तो वह भाग निकला।

चोर पंकज झा पराशर (साहित्य अकादेमीक मैथिली परामर्शदात्री समितिक सदस्य) [जलप्रांतर २०१७ (पृ. १०५)]:



'बेश, तँ सुनू। 1354 मे फिरोजशाह तुगलक के फौज जखन बंगाल सँ दिल्ली घुरि रहल छल, तँ कोसीक प्रवाह बहुत तेज छलै। तुगलकी सेना जखन कोसी के किनार पर पहुँचल, तँ कोसीक ओहि पार मे हाजी शम्सउद्दीन इलियास के सेना तुगलकी सेना सँ मोकाबला करबाक लेल अस्त्र-शस्त्र ल' कए तैयार छल। ई वएह हाजी शम्सउद्दीन छलाह, जे हाजीपुर आ समस्तीपुर नगर बसौने रहथि। फिरोजशाह तुगलक के सेना संभवतः कूरसेला के आस-पास कोसी के तेज धार देखि कए सोच मे पड़ि गेल। पानिक रफ्तार देखि कए तुगलकी सेना कें नदी पार करबाक हिम्मत नहि भ' रहल छलै। अंततः तुगलकी सेनापति तय कयलनि, जे नदीक किनारे-किनार उत्तर दिस बढ़ल जाय। जतय जा कए नदीक पाट कनें कम चौड़ि पड़य, ओतय पानिक थाह लेल जायत। एहि आशा मे फौज उत्तर दिस बढ़ैत रहल। कुरसेला सँ सय कोस आगाँ गेलाक बाद कोसी के पेट कनें शिकस्त चुझैलै। कोसी ओतहि पहाड़ सँ नीचाँ उतरैत अछि। पानिक वेग के अनुमान एहि सँ कयल जा सकैए, जे पाँच-पाँच सय मनक पाथर कोसी मे खढ़ जकाँ बहि रहल छल। तुगलकी सेनापति कें जतय नदी पार करब कनें आसान चुझैलनि, ओतय एक लाइन मे सैकड़ों टा हाथी कें ठाढ़ क' देल गेल। नीचाँ वला लाइन मे बड़का-बड़का रस्सा लटका देल गेल, जे जँ क्यो पानि मे भासि जायत, रस्सा के मदति सँ निकालि लेल जायत। एहि तरहें फिरोजशाह तुगलकक सेना कोसी पार क' गेल। हाजी शम्सउद्दीन सपनो मे नहि सोचनें छल,जे तुगलकी सेना कोसी पार क' जायत। जखन हाजी शम्सउद्दीन कें पता लगलै जे तुगलकी सेना कोसी पार क' चुकल अछि, तँ ओ डरे सँ पड़ा गेल। तँ एहि कोसीक तेज धार के ल' कए एतेक आत्मविस्वास मे छल हाजी शम्सउद्दीन।'

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(These are just a few examples. Thief Pankaj Jha Parashar's (Member, Sahitya Akademi's Maithili Advisory Committee) "Jalprantar 2017" is a pirated book, and the entire book is shamelessly filled paragraph by paragraph from Dinesh Kumar Mishraji's books.)

Chapter 2

Gharāṛī (Novel) (1973)

This novel was published by the Akhil Bharatiya Mithila Sangh (Babu Saheb Chaudhary). Babu Saheb Chaudhary also has a foreword titled "Samasya". And Sushil dedicates this novel to his maternal home. In a brief author's statement, he invites you on a journey to a desert, but there are also oases, where date palms and water are found.

The novel begins on the reader's (Pāṭhak Jī) veranda. There are two chests, a stool, two she-buffaloes, a cow, and a pair of bulls. The barren field is growing cactus; the barren land is more attached to the dried twigs—the play of nature!

After setting up all the arrangements, the novelist introduces Ratan, a military man.

Here, one also learns about language. Sushil did not unnecessarily use 'ka' and 'ta' even in 1973. In the PDF, where it appears initially, he has crossed it out with a pen; the later version is correct. In this novel, there is also a love relationship between a Mallah girl and a Brahmin's son. So, does this prove that someone who is proficient in language can also think ahead, and that their subject matter is also forward-thinking? Both of these works were suppressed in the mainstream. Udaychandra Jha 'Vinod' from Dulaha village, who is mediocre and has a reactionary ideology (his deceit regarding Sharadindu Choudhary and Premlata Mishra 'Prem' is recorded in Videha's Sharadindu Choudhary special issue and Premlata Mishra 'Prem' special issue), was accepted in the mainstream. But Sushil, also from Dulaha village, who is far ahead of him in language, thought, subject matter, and literary standard, and belongs to his

caste, was suppressed. Why wouldn't he be rejected in the mainstream? The pseudocritics either haven't even heard his name, or they engage in such charades.

Ratan's share of ancestral land (gharāṛī) has been plowed by someone else. Lalbabu has gotten it plowed. His younger brother didn't even take his share; why did Lalbabu have Ratan's share plowed? Lalbabu is ready to exchange it (he has filed a case against Ratan later on, for reasons that will be explained), but Ratan wants this exact share of land; why would he uproot himself and go elsewhere? But this information will be found by digging deeper into the novel's details. Also, Ratan, after his father's death, went to the military and was out of touch with the village, that too when he was fifteen years old. For physical fitness, he claimed to be twenty years old and enlisted. No word from him for fifteen years. His brother Mahadev lives on Lalbabu's mercy, surviving. His mother and younger sister, who used to run errands, were swept away in a flood. His anger is natural. But the reader has to guess the plot; Abhiram Jha talks about a forgotten story. Buchchan, the reader's (Pāṭhak Jī) eldest son. Buchchan is good at playing sarō (a game). He is straightforward. Lalbabu used to understand which bamboo would be good for a dāhā (a type of tool) and would get it made. Just as the reader (Pāṭhak Jī) does not set his pieces (goti), he also has differences of opinion with the reader (Pāṭhak Jī). The novelist introduces the reader's (Pāṭhak Jī) granddaughter, Kumkum. Kumkum will have a big role later; for now, she is crying. Her terrylene frock caught fire and got burnt. The reader (Pāṭhak Jī) is leaving for the hospital. First section ends.

At the Bagmati Kathak Hospital, due to Lalbabu's (Laliteshwar Choudhary) influence, a five-bigha piece of land was given to him. The reader's (Pāṭhak Jī) contribution was physical, not monetary. Buchchan and his youth brigade volunteered their labor. And the reason for this charity? His son was studying medicine in Darbhanga at that time, and he is now at this hospital. Far-sighted thinking! And the reader (Pāṭhak Jī) takes Kumkum to this hospital, where a nurse from the Mallah caste is, and Lalbabu's son, the Brahmin Dr. Binayak, is the doctor. Lalbabu also arrives at the hospital. He is not interested in these matters; his mind is focused on the matter of Ratan, who had gone to the reader's (Pāṭhak Jī) place in the morning. Second section ends.

The third section begins with gossip flowing freely by the pond called Nanu Pokhri. There is a panchayat (village council) meeting to decide whether to reconcile Ratan and Lalbabu or not. The reader's (Pāṭhak Jī) younger son Malay, the one who had brought the terrylene frock for Kumkum, and Lalbabu's younger son Ajit, both have come to the village from college in Muzaffarpur during the summer break. They are both there. Vividh Bharati is broadcasting the Jaimala program by Beheda Rahman. In the PDF, Sushilji has crossed out and substituted Amin Sayani, but Amin Sayani used to do the Binaca Geetmala program on Radio Ceylon; Jaimala for soldiers might be on Vividh Bharati with various artists, and Amin Sayani could do that, and Beheda Rahman too. So we are proceeding with the printed version. The panchayat is being held at the library established in the name of Sundar Jha, a winner of the Dhaut Pariksha, by the Nanu Pokhri. Lalbabu is ready to exchange the land; he is even willing to give two kathas extra, but Ratan wants that exact share of land, and he will go to Tamasa (a river where rituals are performed) [i.e., he is adamant]. Section ends.

Fourth section begins. Ratan's younger brother Mahadev is murdered! Ratan is accused. He flees. But Buchchan testifies in his favor at the police station, saying that since he hasn't been in the village for 4-5 days, how could he commit the murder? He has 4-5 people with him, maybe 10-15. The reader (Pāṭhak Jī) is stunned. Lalbabu is silent. And Batthan Babu is watching everyone's expressions. Batthan Babu had heard Ratan's side from Buchchan, and Buchchan is giving his statement as per Batthan Babu's instructions. A twist within a twist. Section ends.

Fifth section. The Brahmin Dr. Binayak and the Mallah nurse Karuna. Karuna says this marriage is impossible; she is of low caste, a Mallah's daughter, and Binayak is a big man. Binayak disagrees. And he says that what he will do will drive the fear from Karuna's heart. But Karuna slaps him and leaves. However, in the sleeping state, the novelist troubles him by narrating a dream; Binayak also has that love. And Binayak is drowning like a Tamasa (a river) filled with poison. He thinks Karuna is a coward. But the novelist introduces an old man with a stick into his dream, who tells Binayak that the one whom Binayak considers strong is actually weak due to the suffocating norms of society, and he gives him a chakra (discus), a sudarshan (conch), and a trishul (trident), telling him to use them. He says, why not act with courage? What will be achieved with just false promises? Women have no faith in society. But Binayak says his

promise is true. He says this while scratching his head. Malay and Ajit take Binayak out for a walk.

Sixth section: After Mahadev's murder, Lalbabu arranged his Shraddh (funeral feast) quite well. But Batthan Babu and the reader (Pāṭhak Jī) are not unaware of the reason for this generosity. They have no doubt about who is behind Mahadev's murder. But they lack the strength to openly oppose it. And meanwhile, Lalbabu also wants to keep these two together and also maintains cordial relations with Batthan Babu. There is a rumor that Santraj's son Ratan has come at night to meet Buchchan. Paragas's father, Saryu Mandal, died two years ago. Lalbabu had paid all the expenses for his Shraddh. That is why Paragas's family is indebted to him. Paragas had passed matriculation; Lalbabu had his fees waived. He had tried to get a grant for a backward class, but Lalbabu twisted his words and kept him close, giving him three bighas of land, but there is no written record. And finally, some humor regarding the welcome of Batthan Babu's in-law—tea was served to him in a glass, but it was too hot; he fluttered like a rooster that had been given too much salt. Sixth section ends.

Meanwhile, Ratan is under the shelter of his friend, Avadhesh, a devotee of Lord Shiva. Avadhesh had run away from Kapileshwar Sthan after stealing something, and after passing middle school, he wrote his name at Kapileshwar High School. Ratan goes to the Bhootnath temple at Nimtala Ghat to seek refuge with Lord Shiva. He meets Avadhesh, who lives with his wife Sunita on Bhupen Bose Avenue. Ratan is in rags! The big officer Avadhesh is standing on the stairs, capturing the sight of Ratan's poverty. Seventh section ends.

Ratan and Avadhesh go hunting for wild fowl together. There is a warrant against Ratan. He needs bail. A letter arrives, from Avadhesh's brother. They wanted to get Dr. Binayak married to their sister Prema; Lalbabu was also agreeable. But now Avadhesh has to think. Binayak is Binayak, but Lalbabu? Ratan says, marriage is with the girl, not the family, but one also has to consider the family. The letter says Lalbabu wants the matter settled quickly. This raises suspicion. Earlier, he never spoke openly due to the lure of money. Eighth section ends.

Karuna comes to the reader's (Pāṭhak Jī) courtyard with Kumkum; the weather has become pleasant. Lalbabu asks Karuna to request a transfer to another place. She signs the application. Lalbabu leaves. Karuna cries. Seeing her, Kumkum also cries. The reader (Pāṭhak Jī) arrives. He asks Kumkum why she is crying, and she reveals the secret: Lalbabu had been pressuring Karuna, making her sign some paper. Section nine ends.

Conversation between Karuna and Binayak. Karuna's gaze falls on Lalbabu's photograph. Binayak is firm. Section ten ends.

Conversation between the reader (Pāṭhak Jī) and Batthan Babu. The reader (Pāṭhak Jī) has understood something. Before giving Karuna the job, Lalbabu used to talk about some condition with the Mallahs. When asked, he avoided it, saying he wanted to sow jeera (cumin) in the Digrasari pond. But no pond was given to the Mallahs by Lalbabu for jeera cultivation. So what was the matter that the Mallahs and Lalbabu understood? Karuna's education was from 'Catholic Church School' and 'Chapman Girls School' in Muzaffarpur. Kumkum had asked the reader (Pāṭhak Jī) whose daughter Karuna Didi was. Didi used to tell Babu that she was his daughter and also gave him money. Did Karuna sign a document? The reader (Pāṭhak Jī) asks Binayak to ask Karuna. Binayak asks her, and she cannot refuse. And then conversation between Binayak and Karuna; Binayak does not let his outburst fall on Karuna. Section eleven ends.

On Avadhesh's recommendation, Ratan is a Security Advisor in Kolkata. He goes to Muzaffarpur for the court date but does not go to the village. He meets Shéfali with Avadhesh. During the conversation, Shéfali says Avadhesh gave jobs to many Maithils, but they all keep criticizing him. Shéfali says her uncle is a lawyer; he says Ratan will win, but the real murderer must also be found. Ratan believes the real murderer is Lalbabu's henchman, Paragas. Avadhesh tells Ratan about another letter: Binayak has fallen in love with Karuna and wants to marry her. Shéfali's father is Ratan's Security Officer. Shéfali's uncle is Kamal Sarkar, a lawyer. Shéfali's father, Rai Ji, is Maithil, and her mother is Bengali. Shéfali has also written several books in Maithili. The incident between Shéfali and Ratan! Section twelve ends.

Lalbabu sends Karuna's transfer letter, but Binayak sends Karuna on leave and has the letter returned by the postman with 'Not Available' written. The postman is a young man whom Binayak had tried hard to get a job. Lalbabu tries to get rid of Karuna through Paragas, but his wife is disturbed by hearing two words, "See, you'll be destroyed." Malay and Ajit are in the village during the hot summer. Paragas goes with four men, but Karuna fights back fiercely and frees herself. Hearing her scream, Malay, Ajit, and the dresser, Siricharan, arrive. Karuna recognizes Paragas among the four. Section thirteen ends.

Karuna's transfer letter was returned once. Now Lalbabu is looking for some other means; he is wondering what to do with this stubborn woman. The lawyer said Ratan will be acquitted. If they get Karuna and Paragas married, the matter will be settled. He returns home. His wife believes that the delay in Binayak's marriage is due to the thirty thousand rupees and a car demanded by him. Section fourteen ends.

Thanks to Mr. Rai, Ratan got a job and bail. Lalbabu's wife gets a hint that Karuna is Ratan's sister, Munia; she has a birthmark on her wrist, just like the one Paragas's mother mentioned. Lalbabu regrets why he got stubborn for money; he could have gotten Binayak married to Avadhesh's sister. A conversation takes place; the wife says Binayak and Karuna are already married. Lalbabu pushes her, but Binayak steps in between, and Lalbabu retreats like a scalded cat. Section fifteen ends.

Karuna moves into the staff quarters with Binayak. Batthan Babu, the reader (Pāṭhak Jī), and Mansur Nadaph go to appease Lalbabu. Paragas was always Buchchan's follower, but where is he now? Karuna's transfer letter arrives again, this time by special messenger. Karuna receives the letter. Binayak is furious. He calls her low, a scoundrel. He says, where will caste and religion go! He calls her low! A whore! But upon hearing the word 'Pranesh' (Beloved), Binayak melts. Karuna puts a folded paper in Binayak's hand. Binayak reads it and feels ashamed, apologizing. Karuna resigns. The news spreads. Lalbabu starts eating and drinking. He says if Binayak comes home, he will leave the house. Lalbabu even goes on a hunger strike. He asks Paragas to play his final role. Section sixteen ends.

The final section is seventeen. The day of Durga Visarjan (immersion). For Durga Puja, three plays are staged: two in Maithili and one in Hindi. Today's Maithili play is 'Kuhes'. Binayak refuses to play Ramkumar's part; he plays the doctor's part. Ajit plays Ramkumar, and Malay plays the highly educated youth Shankar. Buchchan plays the bride's father, Subansh. Playing a part doesn't make one that; Buchchan is herding everyone. After the court date, Ratan also comes to the village at Avadhesh and Buchchan's request to see the Durga Puja. There is a rumor in the village that Karuna is not a Mallah's daughter; Ratan talked to her a couple of times, and he guesses that she might indeed be his sister Munia. The women's gossip makes Ratan ponder. Ratan stays with Buchchan. It's around four o'clock; the play is about to end. The immersion was delayed. Karuna brings her father every year; he has also come this time. Paragas is behind Ratan. At the end of Navgachuli, there is dust; he is hidden behind a tree. But he falls into a trap set for Lalbabu; Ratan was behind him. The truth is revealed; Lalbabu is taken to the hospital. Then, the revelation of secrets and repentance. And the drama of Vijayadashami ends.

Chapter 3

Gāmbālī (Novel) (1982)

Everyone's eyesore, Gāmbālī, is gone, and the thorns too!

Those who liked her, those who didn't, and those who were indifferent—all three types are happy. Who will perform her last rites? Yadav society or Brahmin society? People from Yadav society and Brahmin society go to the landlord, Sonmani Jha. He is walking step by step, engaged in consultation.

The Yadav society performs Gāmbālī's funeral rites together.

People from the Goar Toli started calling her Gāmbālī (village girl), and then people from the Babhan Toli, Kayasth Toli, and Jolaha Toli also started calling her Gāmbālī.

Gāmbālī's husband was old. She was his third wife. There were no children from the first, so he remarried, and there were children from the second, and also from the first. And then the third marriage was for pleasure. There's a saying of Babu Pairookh, how many wives can one have?

The people made Gyanchan Yadav, i.e., Gyanchanma, a murderer; he went into her house by force and then created a stir in the village.

Gāmbālī remained alive; her will to live became even stronger later. She lived with great pride, not caring about anyone. For those who saw her as a whore, she was nothing. She laughed and joked with anyone who had a sister-in-law relationship with her. The promotion of calling her Gāmbālī started from the Goar Toli and spread throughout the village.

But Gāmbālī had no connection with her old in-laws' family in this village. However, in terms of food and lifestyle, she was different from the Brahmins.

After her death today, she has no shortage of admirers. She came with pride and left with pride.

Gāmbālī was married to a wealthy, arrogant old man. She was his third wife. The old man married a second time for companionship, and there were children from the second and first. The third wife was for pleasure, just for show.

The cunning people tried to drive her away and made Gyanchanma into a murderer.

And the novelist begins with Gyanchan Yadav's story.

He called elders 'Baba', 'Kaka', 'Bhai', and younger ones 'Baua', 'Bachcha', 'Nunu'. There was no courtyard where he did not enter. He would address women as 'Dai', 'Kaki', 'Bahan', 'Bachiya' until his mouth was sore. But when he went to the courtyards of young women, it was something to see. If an old woman persisted, he would enter the courtyard of a beautiful woman. Women

of the category of 'Babi', 'Mai', 'Pius' used to say, 'How does he practice medicine, being so shameless?'

Gyanchan was a lover of songs. He was very fond of foreign dances and nautanki (folk theatre), which was considered an art form for the young, but the noble and the new-generation gentlemen would sit in the front. He knew all the songs of the foreign dance by heart. He could sing Vidyapati and Nirgun Nacari in the same way, which pleased the Brahmins; his village was a Brahmin village. He also remembered the bhajans of Mira and Kabir. But for the songs and dances of Jalim Singh, his mind would race, he would feel hesitant, but he didn't dare.

His medical practice brought him fame, but many people were jealous. Then he felt like buying a car (harmonium), which his grandmother had saved up for a lifetime, in the form of silver coins. The harmonium, a watch, and a horse came from the Sonpur Mela. These things caught some people's eyes. The landlord's own nephew, Gena Jha, was Gyanchan's close friend and became an expert at riding the horse. There were a few watches and a few harmoniums in the village, but whenever there was an occasion like kirtan or asthajam, Gyanchan's watch and harmonium would be used. If someone's child had a naming ceremony, his watch would be present at the soiree. His influence extended over ten villages.

Meanwhile, Gāmbālī's pain increased. Gyanchan wouldn't go there riding a horse, just had words. Ramadhar Agilesua was there. But Gena Jha roamed everywhere on horseback. But Gāmbālī praised his watch and requested to see the horse. So he brought the horse for her to see. But then other people also gathered there. Had Gāmbālī been possessed? People crowded to see her body. People were covering their mouths. Then Gāmbālī regained consciousness. Gāmbālī tells Gyanchan that she has stomach pain, it's not a ghost. Gyanchan gives her new medicine, telling her to throw away the old one.

Then begins the story of Kiran Dai's Dwarika's Guru Maharaj. Kiran Dai is confused about where to place Guru Maharaj. Some people had come for the harmonium; Gyanchan has to arrange a 'jogar' (offering) for the Guru Maharaj as per tradition.

Kiran Dai, the niece of Kantir Babu, is a child widow. Before the consummation of her marriage, her bangles were removed; she became an ascetic, spending her eight days (a ritual) at Kapileshwar. It is said she redeemed her lineage. She meets saints. Saints from Vrindavan and Dwarika praise her greatly.

The Maharaj from Dwarika is wonderful, with a simple appearance, but he does not please her father. He casually said something, but Maharaj kept singing bhajans and moving on, he wouldn't stop. Kiran Dai's voice is so sweet that Maharaj must have liked it. People were pleased. Her father apologized, and Kiran Dai was happy. Then a description of Maharaj. He is not from Dwarika but from Vrindavan. He is a lifelong celibate; he left Vrindavan but not permanently. With such a body, he cannot lead a wayward life. Meanwhile, Gāmbālī was staring intently at Gyanchan, and the landlord was watching her. Gyanchan felt he was caught. There were three or four other child widows. Maharaj sang Bindu Ji's bhajan, then Sur, and then Mira's.

Gyanchan became thoughtful. Would Gāmbālī also become like Kiran Dai one day? There is a kind of energy in all child widows; she has something like Kiran Dai.

Kiran Dai wouldn't become a Sakele; she kept her faith. Ghosts often possessed her.

If not that, she would become a Parmeshwari; the knots in her body could drive anyone mad. It was a matter of a moment or two, then she would wander around Kapileshwar, Videshwar.

If not that, she would become a Ratni, who is fearless in her father's house, protected from all sides. But men would set fire to her, their anger is not taken. So Ratni fell. Ratni was broken; she didn't have the courage to face society.

No, Gāmbālī wouldn't become anything. She is invincible. She would never give in. She got up. She is young. No one can catch her. In the grasslands, the

mountain stands still; the stalk flies. He left with the harmonium. That night, Gāmbālī couldn't sleep. Gāmbālī's father was a Pandit; he had taught her to read and write. Sometimes she would read her brother's history and geography books.

Fifteen years had passed since the abolition of the zamindari system, but the tradition of playing the game of sarō in the village continued. The village's khalifa (head of a group) was Dafedar Jadab. Gyanchan was the khalifa's nephew. All of the landlord's (Sonmani Jha) people were the khalifa's followers. Gyanchan was more cunning and agile than all his associates except for a couple. The choupal (village meeting place) would gather around Gyanchan. He would go to Madhubani-Darbhanga to buy medicine and would read newspapers. The India-China war was happening. He would tell everyone about it.

The paddy was being harvested; piles of paddy were spread in the courtyards.

The landlord's nephew, Ramadhar, was more envious of Gyanchan's horse, watch, and harmonium than anyone else. Should a young man wear a watch or cut grass? The matter escalated; Gyanchan punched and landed five or six blows. Gena Jha restrained Gyanchan, the khalifa restrained Ramadhar. The khalifa told Gyanchan not to come to his doorstep—"You are a Dom, I am a Chamar." Ramadhar's side. The khalifa was like a leaf in the wind; he understood the landlord's mind. The khalifa, as a mediator, took Ramadhar and went. The matter spread like gossip. Sonmani Jha scolded his nephew, but the matter was not forgotten. He had laid hands on a Brahmin; the village would become a mess; would there be a 'bhar-changera' (commotion) or a 'bhar-daur' (excommunication)? There would surely be an inquiry.

Sonmani thought: Gyanchan is in everyone's heart, including his own. But when he started to weigh Gyanchan, he couldn't find a single grain of hope. That one grain had been crushed in his eyes. And the decision was made: to crush the snake's hood. It's better to suppress the conflict. Gyanchan's father had taken a stubborn animal under his wing, and it had become a bull. From that, Gyanchan's lineage had grown. Now, with Gāmbālī's medicine and

support, it had grown further. No matter how much water and stones he threw, Gyanchan would just take a stroll around the village.

Now Gyanchan couldn't bear to come every day; everyone's behavior had changed. People were looking for a reason to quarrel. They were waiting for him at one place, watching from another. He was making many packets (of medicine) in Gāmbālī's courtyard. Why is Gyanchan making so many packets? Did we have a fight? Only we are the ones investigating—Gāmbālī asked. An intimate conversation. This is what is poisoning me—Gyanchan said.

If one hasn't seen Rama, what can one see of others? Gāmbālī retorted.

Gāmbālī asks about his marriage. He replies—Marriage happened and it didn't—marriage happened by a certain measure, that's how it is in youth. There's an engagement between us, maybe it will happen somewhere—Gyanchan says.

Gyanchan is a doctor. Gyanchan tells everyone his matters, because the relationship between a doctor and patient is like that of father and son—Gyanchan says.

Is there no other relationship?—Gāmbālī asks.

The one who made even the brave tremble during zamindari times, how did he become so soft-spoken? A sign of taking the bait...

One night, one bigha of Gyanchan's paddy was cut. The 'Gangajali' paddy was very beautiful.

Theft does not happen in Rampur village.

But this...

People were surprised; the dogs didn't bark.

But Gyanchan did nothing in the morning.

They were waiting for the right time, but there was no opportunity to provoke Gyanchan. The matter was building up, but Gyanchan broke the buildup at the very start.

Dogs bite strangers, jackals bite those they know, and women and thieves bite everyone.

Gyanchan took three or four people and started hiding in the field.

But one night he fell asleep. A woman named Kari came to ask for a black lota in the late night. Kari is a well-known woman from the landlord's house. She has been around for a long time. He didn't trust her. He kept her in a bind and took a whip and a stick himself. The others took spears and axes and left. The paddy was being covered with mats. There were three or four of them and fifteen or twenty others. Gyanchan's presence of mind was amazing. Attacking now was not right; they too had weapons. He planned to attack when they lifted the load and left, catching Ramadhar and the others. People who steal crops are not thieves; they would not face him.

Ramadhar was caught. Parao Jha got him released, and there was talk of the police and the complexities of law.

Later, Gyanchan got four or five blows, but Gena Jha and Parao Jha gave them.

The khalifa's son, Baiju, started sitting with the Brahmins. A fight over a bamboo strip started between the khalifa and Gyanchan. The khalifa gave in, but Baiju was not one to agree.

Sonmani Jha (the landlord) and Satajib Jha were outwardly arrogant but inwardly weak.

The landlord grabbed Gāmbālī's wrist and put a bundle of money in her hand. Gāmbālī threw the bundle into the stove.

Gyanchan sold his horse.

Then the novelist talks about Gāmbālī's parental home and society.

A saint didn't let a Bhil woman touch the water of the Pampasar, fearing pollution. The Pampasar dried up. Purushottam Ram allowed her to bathe there; the Ganga had mixed into it, and the water of Pampasar became nectar.

Gāmbālī came out of her courtyard and went to Gyanchan. She placed her temple against Gyanchan's chest. Gyanchan's grandmother watched everything. Gāmbālī returned. By dawn, the matter had been whispered about. The landlord pushed Gāmbālī, and she was shoved into Gyanchan's doorway. And Gāmbālī became Gāmbālī that very day. Gyanchan filled the Panji (record). Gāmbālī's all pain vanished then. Gyanchan opened a middle school in the village on the bullock's back. He also got the road leveled. Rampur started being talked about in surrounding villages. The zamindari system ended, and the wealthy people started buying up fallow lands and the landlord's mango groves for a pittance.

That day was the 'Ghadi Puja' (worship of the watch). A dispute arose over the strip. Gāmbālī became a widow for the second time that day. The landlord and the khalifa had to spend twelve years in jail.

No one understood Gāmbālī's story in such detail; everyone hears about her after her death.

Sondai's father sold her to a man from Dakshinaha when she was nine years old. She left her husband and remarried. The first husband came, but the college-going and foreign-returned people of the village drove him away. Satajib Jha's son married his girlfriend... Ramadhar's son...

Two or three Jadabs are handling Gāmbālī's funeral rites. Gāmbālī has a fifteen-year-old son. For the funeral pyre, seven men are needed. The word spreads: Ramadhar's son, then Baiju's son, and then others start joining. Bamboo is being cut from the 'Jhagraua Beat'. The trees Gyanchan had planted have now become someone else's. The funeral rites are performed there. The library will be named 'Gāmbālī Smarak Pustakalaya' (Gāmbālī Memorial Library).

Chapter 4

Bhāmatī (Drama) (First staging 1991, Publication 2013)

Preface: Sangita Menon writes: Two major sub-schools of Advaita Vedanta emerged after Shankar: Bhāmatī and Vivarana. The Bhāmatī school is named after Vachaspati Mishra's (9th century) commentary on Shankar's Brahma Sutra Bhashya, while the Vivarana school is named after Prakashatman (10th century)'s commentary on Padmapada's Panchapadika, which itself is a commentary on Shankar's Brahma Sutra commentary.

Maya is responsible for the creation of the world. Avidya (ignorance) is responsible for confusing the distinct existence of the self (Atman) and the non-self (Anatman). Avidya conceals Brahman and creates the world. As a result, the individual (jiva) acts as an agent and experiencer in the limited world. The differences in doctrine between the two sub-schools of Advaita Vedanta can be understood through their different interpretations of the nature and locus of Avidya and Maya. Shankar considered Avidya to be beginningless. He believed that investigating the origin of Avidya is a process based on Avidya itself and therefore futile. However, Shankar's disciples paid more attention to this concept, giving rise to the two sub-schools. The main issue distinguishing the Bhāmatī and Vivarana schools is the nature and locus of Avidya. According to the Bhāmatī school, the jiva (individual self) is the locus and object of Avidya. According to the Vivarana school, Brahman is the locus of Avidya. The Bhāmatī school believes that Brahman cannot be the locus of Avidya; rather, as Ishvara, He controls it. The individual's ignorance performs two functions: it conceals Brahman and, through projection (vikshepa), creates a separate world. Mula-Avidya (primordial ignorance) is a universal ignorance equivalent to

Maya, controlled by Ishvara. The Vivarana school believes that since Brahman alone exists, Brahman is the locus and object of Avidya. Through epistemological discussions, the unreality of duality between Brahman and the world is established. The Vivarana school answers the question by stating that Brahman is both "pure consciousness" and "universal ignorance," claiming that valid experience (prama) in the everyday world is considered Avidya, while pure consciousness is the essential nature of Brahman.

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Vachaspati Mishra discusses the Brahmin's connection with the world and differs from Shriharsha. He co-existed more peacefully with the Naiyyayikas (logicians) than Shriharsha did, considering Nyaya capable of explaining worldly reality and Advaita capable of explaining transcendental reality. Vachaspati also wrote a commentary on the Nyaya Sutras. Thus, like Dharmakirti, he was esteemed in both Advaita and Nyaya, and like Shankar, in Samkhya and Advaita—meaning he was respected in two philosophies each. However, this peace was broken by Shriharsha's Khandanakhandakhadyam. Shankar Mishra (in Bhedaratna) even stooped to incivility: "Only the Tarkikas (logicians) are active for the protection of Bhedaratna, so we, the Vedantins (Advaitins), are cutting off the heads of these thieves." (This Shankar Mishra is different from Adi Shankaracharya—a disrespectful target at Adi Shankaracharya).

The Drama Bhāmatī

Thus, it is established that the elderly Vachaspati was inclusive. Therefore, the aggressive and eccentric portrayal of him in the drama Bhāmatī at some point does not align with his philosophy.

The drama focuses on Bhāmatī. There is a feminist discourse (especially in Shambhavi; in Bhāmatī as well, but due to Bhāmatī's suicide attempt, it falls into a lower category within feminism). Social anomalies are also depicted. The dialogues are suitable for the staging of the play. There are 11 characters, including Bhāmatī, with only one other female character. Considering the

limited number of female actors or men playing female roles, this is acceptable. The first act begins after the death of Vachaspati's parents. There are descriptions of the scene, costumes, and stage setting. Bhāmatī's heart fills with joy upon hearing the news that her husband Vachaspati has gone to visit the birthplace of his guru Shankaracharya and will also see his places of work. A villain, Purandar, also appears; he wants to make some money, open schools, etc. Later, he becomes even more audacious.

In the first act, Bhāmatī is 25-26 years old.

The second act also begins with descriptions of costumes, stage setting, and scene. The second act is set 15-16 years later. So now Bhāmatī is 40-42 years old. Vachaspati appears in this act, seeing Bhāmatī for the first time, as he was engrossed in his scholarly work.

In the third act, Bhāmatī is shown giving a letter. In the letter, she blames herself for distracting him, causing the delay in his commentary on Shankar's Brahma Sutra Bhashya. She is about to jump into a pond, but this is not described in the play. In the next scene, with the entry of Vachaspati, who pulls out a completely drenched Bhāmatī from the pond, it becomes clear. Therefore, he named the book Bhāmatī. And the play ends.

In folklore, there is a description of how, when the oil in the lamp ran out, she made a wick from her sari, and after completing the book, upon seeing her naked, he named the book Bhāmatī for her sacrifice. However, perhaps for staging purposes, the playwright made this change. Also, Bhaskaracharya named his mathematical text after his daughter, Lilavati, but in that book, the questions are often addressed to Lilavati. [O Lilavati, intelligent girl, if you understand addition and subtraction, tell me the sum of the numbers 2, 5, 32, 193, 18, 10, and 100, and also tell me what remains after subtracting from 10,000.]

Chapter 5

Asmitā (Short Story Collection) (2016)

Asmitā is a collection of short stories. While reviewing the mainstream Maithili stories, I inadvertently remember Sushil, seeing the weakness in the craft of mainstream story writers. Attempts have been made to suppress Sushil due to the weakness of Maithili criticism. Mainstream story writers, who do not even understand the meaning of a short story, kept wandering in literature devoid of readers, and Sushil was forgotten.

Baghotiya

'Baghotiya' demonstrates how fake news is spread, and Bihari is brought in and then disappears. You don't even realize why the Bihari came and where he went. Kites fly in the sky, but the one flying the kite is someone else. Baghotiya (a bird of prey) was lifting children; the issues of land, occupation, votes for two rupees, the vote machine. And what was Baghotiya? Nothing. Why nothing? Look at the craft of the short story 'Titait-Bhijait'. See how it progresses, how the story seizes control of the kite-flyers, exposing them. A father is a father indeed. While listening to the story of Baghotiya, it unravels all modern problems. Baghotiya is Sushil's best story.

My Latest Photograph

Even in my latest photograph, at the editor's insistence, the author gets his photo taken; a bio is needed with the photo. But that storywriter describes his social and economic circumstances.

Prem-Prasang (Love Affair)

In 'Prem-Prasang', the conversations between husband and wife discuss all kinds of matters related to love. 'Sahayatri' and 'Moh' also belong to their own realm. Through the medium of people from different fields, I have described various small problems and emotions that we experienced not today but twenty years ago.

Prem Ne Baḍi Upajay (Love Does Not Grow in a Garden)

"Her face, filled with smiles, white as the Colgate toothpaste model, with a row of pomegranate seeds-like teeth, her unwavering eyes resting on me."

Now, a mainstream children's literature writer, awarded by the Sahitya Akademi, would call pomegranate 'anar' [Anar – Children's Short Story Collection (Maithili) – Author Narayanji; Sahitya Akademi Delhi Children's Literature Award 2024 <https://sahitya-akademi.gov.in/pdf/Pressrelease_BSP-2024.pdf>]. And after the Colgate toothpaste model, describing pomegranate seeds with such finesse can only be done by a story writer of Sushil's caliber. You are right, this excerpt is from the best Maithili love story, 'Prem Ne Baḍi Upajay'. Love does not grow in a garden, nor does a love story.

"Whose fault is it in the end? This is just a game to be played. If we don't all play, the world will stop playing?"

Pipani Par Nor (Finger on the Lip)

Here, the story begins with a morning walk. The D.I.G. Sahib communicates through gestures. The fruit of action, releasing the new recruits into the forest; their 'Vande Mataram' will play. The D.I.G. Sahib says, when you take off the uniform, you become a human; when you wear it, you become a demon. And all the other elements that a modern short story should have.

Pusht.. Pusht.. Pusht (Generation.. Generation.. Generation)

It's the same family affairs. In the village, Asgar the old man and his wife; their children are outside. The story weaves this with artistic craft. The story begins with the Ramayana and ends up somewhere else entirely.

Ekta Kalakar Ki Atmahatyā (A Artist's Suicide)

When the artist gave up art, it was a suicide. And why did he stop painting?

Gharmaṅhā and Sanakirbā

'Gharmaṅhā' and 'Sanakirbā' are stories of the middle class. In 'Gharmaṅhā', a working man's wife seems upset. In 'Sanakirbā', amidst the chaos of the house, there is terrorism, undivided India, and the 'Sanakirbā'.

Gām Sadhbā Hoit Achhi (The Village is Getting Settled)

A story in epistolary style. After retirement, staying in the village to serve it. Medicines, alcohol, feminism, and along with the son and husband. The character of Praveer's mother is the strongest. Some politics of business. Later, it turns out that it was the politics of another medicine shop owner.

Asmitā

Asmitā is the title story. A story of women's empowerment. Just as a woman village head merely signs papers while her husband does all the work, similarly, the woman ward member only signs under coercion. But Minakshi now refuses to do so; she is with other women members and a male member. 'Bhokaṭa' is the story of the widow Savitri and Mantor. 'Nirmal Pramanik' is also there. The real issue is that even in the 'Jaṛiāoṭhā' (community gathering), there is the politics of profit. Later it is revealed that it was the politics of another private tutor's shop. Just like in 'Gām Sadhbā Hoit Achhi', it was the politics of another medicine shop owner. 'Asmitā', 'Bhokaṭa', and 'Asal Bāt Jaṛiāoṭhā' are three weak stories. The story writer seems tired.

Bāt Tākait Ekta Sehantā (A Hawk Waiting by the Road)

Discontentment, Ramanu, the village school. Rabbi, Bhadaai, Kaushiyar, but crops grow in the field all year round. It is neither Rabbi nor Bhadaai; it is cash crop. But the teachers in the village school do not come; those who do come,

come only to sleep. But the buffalo's application was approved; the condition of schools is the same across the country.

Mātsarya (Jealousy)

Ramalal got a payment, two five-hundred rupee notes. Should he recount them? The Payment Babu didn't recount them in front of him. But later, he found out that there was one extra five-hundred rupee note. Should he go back and give it? The narrator skillfully portrays his mental state as the story progresses.

Vigyāpan Karāmāt (The Magic of Advertising)

An agarbatti (incense stick) advertisement comes on TV every day. One for ten rupees, expensive. Panditji's daughter wants it. See the magic of advertising.

Masjid (The Mosque)

Sushil's most discussed story. Devkant's guru has to go far to offer namaz. Devkant decides to build a mosque in the village for his guru, with everyone's cooperation. Devkant tells the journalist—Leave the Ram Mandir in Ayodhya to those people. But they won't leave it, know that... There have been many such examples in the country. Does it make any difference?

Haḍtāl (Strike)

Bhola passed matriculation. He stayed at the 'adda' for a few days, then left the party. Both brothers have two shops; he also wants to open a good shop. For that, he needs capital. So he opened a 'Chah' (tea) shop.

Today there is a strike. Everyone has been threatened not to open their shops. But this shop is open, just a shutter is down. The people from the government party praise him; they see those who are not opening their shops. They have tea

and leave without paying. Then the police come, have tea, and leave without paying.

Then both parties come one after the other.

A pipe gun bullet hits him; he dies. In the evening, a silent procession is taken out in his mourning.

Saḍak (The Road)

A road is being built in the village. But those whose houses fall on the road are protesting. The benefit of the road is that it will lead to the village. A meeting is held. The road will go through the village from end to end. A decision is made. Everyone starts thinking: who will buy a rickshaw, who will run a jeep on hire? If a bus stop forms near the school, some people think about opening shops and a flour mill. Sukru could open a 'Chah' shop. There is great shame in keeping buffaloes; some say it's a 'Naath Kasu' issue, people grab onto caste. He has traveled to Assam and Kolkata several times. But Lambodar Babu...

The road doesn't get built. Well, half a life has already passed.

Katahu Nahi (Nowhere)

The Chaltar (a person) is walking with a limp; he has come out after many days, looking around. The village seems new, like a different village. August 15th, inauguration, Vande Mataram, one end of the rope is placed in Chaltar's hand. One 'thonga' (jute bag) is given to him, another is given. Chhote Babu had passed away; he had told Pritam two days ago to be present on the 15th of August, but Pritam had gone off somewhere with some sister yesterday. He would understand everything here; such things are not hidden. The body shivered.

Sabta Rehal-Khehal (Everything is Ruined)

The ten cars, gossip, then a robbery. Then the R.P.F. arrives. These passengers come once or twice a year; the ten cars are all ruined.

Uttarapaksha (The Subsequent View)

Chapter 1

Theory

Apart from Marxism, other contemporary theories remained distant from politics. However, contemporary theories brought a revolution in philosophy, if not in politics.

Marxism criticizes social reality and makes the dialectical system the basis of its interpretation.

Freud considers all humans to be mysterious. He chooses a literary work for analyzing the author. Neo-Freudianism emphasizes the primacy of cultural elements over biological ones.

Neo-criticism is based on the detailed description of the work.

Now, in philosophy, mathematics and science have become limited to mathematical logic. The study system of philosophy's induction (from particular to general) and deduction (from general to particular) moved towards the analytical system.

Existentialism, humanism, progressivism, romanticism, sociological analysis —all these have preserved their existence by merging into the synthetic system of criticism. Psycho-analysis, due to its emphasis on scientificity, has preserved its existence like the dialectical system.

Post-modernist perspective: Criticism of the totality of scientific knowledge, truth-untruth, description from each one's own perspective, the end of self-centered humor and the sense of good-bad gradually fading, no certainty about when truth becomes untruth, surface-level thinking, not exactly optimism but not pessimism either, what exists is matter-of-factness, the perspective that a thing can be thought of not in one way but in many ways, lack of belief in cause, control, and planned outcomes, rather more belief in outcomes due to coincidence. Democratic and feminist perspectives, along with ideologies like the red flag, and humor and satire as symbols. Post-modernity brought to the fore the issues of many communities and women who were marginalized from the mainstream due to globalization. It opposed ideology and universal goals but could not provide any alternative. Post-modernist thinker Jacques Derrida fragmented language and established that the fragmented parts are dependent on many different bases, and without understanding them, we cannot grasp the meaning of language.

The analytical philosophy of positivism analyzes not objects but linguistic statements and concepts.

Analytical or logical positivism and existentialism were born as a reaction to science. This clarified the ambiguous view of science.

In phenomenology, the given of consciousness is studied in its given form. Experience is the observation of a specific mental fact. This is a means to see the object in an absolute and pure form.

In existentialism, man—only man exists. He is nothing apart from what he creates. He is condemned to be free (Sartre).

Through Hegel's dialectics, emphasis was placed on determining the quality of process and judging existence through the infinite interrelation of analysis and synthesis.

Quantum theory and the uncertainty principle have also influenced modern thought. The internal and external processes behind the appearance of reality

are made possible by the exchange of small elements of force-energy. The uncertainty principle necessitates determining state and form through estimation.

The hypothesis of a universe with more than three dimensions and Stephen Hawking's "A Brief History of Time" are eliminating the existence of God, because the concept of the death of God has also emerged from these. The "God" particle is an attempt to explain the beginning of the universe.

Post-structural methodology connects language meaning, word, its meaning, not with grammatical rules, but with the process of meaning-making. It holds different meanings for all types of individuals and groups. There is no ultimate connection between language and the world. A word and its text do not have a final meaning or a specific meaning of their own. Modern and postmodern logic, reality, dialogue, and exchange of ideas gave birth to modernity.

The new left-wing movement emerged in France. Ideologies like nihilism and anarchism also emerged. These modern thought processes were based on distrust, stepping outside their faith and concepts.

Then began the interpretation of hidden meaning in the text in the context of place-time, and language was made a medium of play—Language Game (Wittgenstein).

Capitalism was born from the industrial revolution. Now, in the post-industrial society, the importance of information and communication has increased over production.

History may not have ended, but traditional history has ended. State, class, nation, party, society, family, morality, marriage—all are being redefined. Many institutions, due to the consequences of constant change, have become fragmented and context-less.

Michel Foucault says—knowledge and truth are created. Deleuze and Guattari say we desire through the other because we are desire machines.

Mikhail Bakhtin takes language as a form of social action. Russian formalist thinkers consider literature merely a specific use of language.

Jean-François Lyotard says—the authenticity of truth and history is only virtual. Baudrillard says—advertising and television have erased the distinction between truth and the virtual. Both are key postmodernist thinkers.

Lacan's specialty is that he applied linguistics to Freud's method. He says the structure of the unconscious is like a language. When a child learns language, a signifier is taught for a signified. Desire, error, and the Other are three facts Lacan presents well. Desire is both need and demand, but it cannot be fragmented into these two forms. Error and emptiness appear in the description of the Other. The subject is a fleeting effect of meaning, and it occurs with the Other when it becomes virtual and becomes the cause of error, from which desire arises.

There are three post-colonial thinkers: Homi K. Bhabha (close to Foucault and Lacan), Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak (close to Foucault and Derrida), and Edward Said (close to Foucault), who explain the work done and theorizing regarding the cunning, weakness, etc., of the former colonizers.

Raymond Williams's study of culture connects literature with economic conditions.

New Historicism compares the linguistics of history and the historicity of linguistics.

Elaine Showalter identifies the mental, biological, and linguistic characteristics of women's writing.

Simone de Beauvoir considers class and caste (which later feminist theory opposed) as obstacles in a woman's commitment to women.

Virginia Woolf considers economic independence and privacy necessary for a woman writer. Her ideas were not considered revolutionary.

Mary Wollstonecraft emphasized incorporating revolution and education based on justice in women's education.

Neo-criticism: Eliot opposed the primacy of emotion in poetry and insisted on making it impersonal. Wimsatt and Wordsworth said criticism should not be based on the poet's intention or historical study. Nor should it be based on the emotional effect on the reader, as that is relative. It should be based on actual linguistics.

English criticism can be traced back to Philip Sidney—he saw poetry in terms of beauty, meaning, and human interest.

John Dryden—considered moral discourse in ancient literature and its benefits and harms.

Samuel Johnson wrote on the tragic and comic elements in Shakespeare's plays.

Rousseau's romanticism does not doubt that man is good (classical critics doubt this, but neo-classical critics say human nature is corrupt, but institutions can make it good), but he also says that institutions are corrupt and only help corrupt people.

Modern situationalism—no question mark on the situation of literature—but structuralism attacked it, and after that, the author lost the right to analyze the text he himself wrote. Post-structuralism said literature is a thing beyond what structuralism understands.

One type of post-structuralism is postmodernity. Post-structuralism said that in literature, structure operates between culture and theory, where some feelings and thoughts are excluded, which oppose continuity.

Deconstruction and postmodernity came after post-structuralism.

Post-colonialism does not accept new forms of colonialism and considers theories of disorder as reasons for not achieving appropriate results for failed objectives.

Structuralism attacked the oppressive Western system and society, and this strengthened Marxism (Althusser). After modernism-situationalism, neo-criticism, structuralism, and post-structuralism came deconstruction and postmodernism, which was called late capitalism (Fredric Jameson).

After the 1970s, the term 'modern' took the form of a theory, and then the term 'post-modern' became a term whose perspective was not worldly important. All life and history up to the modern period became unimportant and ended. This theory became post-history, post-development, and post-causality. The importance of truth and interconnectedness ended.

In magical realism, magical objects are inserted into a realistic situation. The writer uses such experiments to better understand reality.

Post-modernity uses Western bourgeois audio-visual media to call concepts of inequality, injustice, and deprivation merely words that are related to equality, attainment, and justice. Poverty, which is not a problem in the West, is a major problem in India and Nepal today.

Post-modernity is opposed to feminism and Marxism, and feminism and Marxism have opposed it. For example, Marxism is in favor of historical analysis and has strengthened its theory in the context of structuralism-post-structuralism and postmodernism. Marxism emphasizes worldly aspects, but it is not close to utilitarianism and Charvaka philosophy, because utilitarianism and Charvaka philosophy only consider physical needs. Feminist perspectives have also opposed the status quo of postmodernism because until it ends, the situation of women will not improve.

Derrida's deconstruction method brings down a highly placed work/author and elevates the low.

Roland Barthes writes that when a work becomes separate from its author and its analysis begins independently, the work becomes important, which he calls the death of the author.

Post-structuralism destroyed the concept of structuralism being complete and well-structured.

Saussure's theory of language—spoken/written, contemporary literature or the linguistics of historical perspective, any important work or person is important, importance is a feeling, language in contemporary times or its historical perspective; but even this was turned upside down by Derrida's deconstruction theory.

The feminist perspective says that all theories are made by men, so they cannot provide a complete explanation.

Simple humanism arose against all these theories, but it too became a theory. Significant literary creation occurred under it.

Psychoanalysis and the dialectical method, along with Foucault's analysis and Derrida's analysis, remained as enduring paradigms for criticism after being synthesized.

Thus, literature can be idealistic, naturalistic, realistic, humanistic, socialistic, or empiricistic-sensual-realistic. Or it can be pragmatic, which includes utilitarianism, pragmatism, behaviorism, causation, economism, and consequentialism. This is the modern perspective.

According to Julia Kristeva, a son distances himself from his mother, but in a daughter, those rhythms and qualities persist, so even when she distances

herself from her mother, she remains close to culture. The reason for Julia Kristeva's male-centric and stubborn approach is this.

In her presentation "Word, Dialogue and Novel", Julia Kristeva proposed the concept of inter-textuality, meaning no text can exist in isolation. She calls the text a compilation. The text is a subject of practice and production. It produces two types of voices: the voice of socio-cultural texts and the voice of literary texts. The text incorporates ideological conflict and tension. In Julia Kristeva's longitudinal axis, there is a direct dialogue between the author and the reader. That is, there is a direct dialogue between the content of the envelope and the address written on the envelope. But in Julia Kristeva's vertical axis, the "text" dialogues with mainstream literature and also with events that occurred in a short period. That is, there is a dialogue between the text and its context; one author's text dialogues with another author's text. When these two axes intersect, a word or text is produced in which at least one other text can be read. Julia Kristeva describes the author's authority and duty as preserving speech and as a text separate from the human being. Julia Kristeva's presentation "Word, Dialogue and Novel" furthers Mikhail Bakhtin's concept. Additionally, Julia Kristeva analyzes language as a sign and symbol. When a child communicates through rhythms as a sign, there is no structure or meaning. But as he grows, he understands the difference between self and other, starts speaking, and moves out of the courtyard. And then he distances himself from his mother. However, he does not immediately move away from the symbolic; rather, he oscillates between the semiotic and the symbolic. The semiotic is feminine, musical, poetic, and rhythmic; the symbolic is masculine, rule-based, and structured. The devaluation of women's bodies and their characters in cinema and other media by men stems from the fear of the mother's body threatening their existence. But a baby child remains close to its mother, so it is more imbued with feminine semiotic qualities—musical, poetic, rhythmic. Thus, while it rejects the mother, it also defines itself in relation to her. Cornel supports Jacques Derrida's intervention in feminist ideology through his phallocentric deconstruction theory, and Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak welcomes it. Derrida's focus on the limitations of the phallocentric perspective is a meaningful intervention, and it has made it possible to redefine the components of symbols under a process. Derrida sees the impossibility of simplifying the factors of dialogue; it cannot be simplified. So, women should not be seen as objects of inference and knowledge. Feminism should not be seen in relation to masculinity; rather, there is a need to create a separate space

for feminism. Derrida says a text is roughly a political act that can be defined as a dialogue concerning power relations. However, Derrida is accused of trying to appropriate the voice of women under the guise of male discourse, to snatch the authority that women have painstakingly achieved, the authority with which they speak for themselves. Derrida is not concerned with women's daily problems and powerlessness. Derrida takes deconstruction positively and places feminism as a form of dualism in existential metaphysics/ logic, like man-woman. Derrida exposes the obsession with a center-based structure in Western philosophy. Structuralism, inspired by Saussure's linguistics, attempts a scientific analysis of cultural existence. Levi-Strauss's structural anthropology does the same for folklore. Similarly, attempts at structural analysis are constantly made in literature for prose and poetry. But Derrida exposes this. Structuralism seeks a solid basis for its analysis, a center outside the system from which it can conduct its scientific analysis, but that is just an illusion of a philosopher. How can a folktale have a permanent or fixed structure? So, to study the structure of a folktale, you have to determine that idea or center based on which you will analyze it. Derrida says that for any structure, its conceptualization/idea is necessary; then by joining the fragments, you build it. But a structure is impossible without an end. And this is true for literature as well. As long as you do not assume a self-evident meaning for a work, you cannot find its structure, because meaning, i.e., the end, determines its structure. So, the structuralist already knows the meaning and can then analyze its different parts and their interrelationships. And this pre-known, self-evident meaning before analysis is Derrida's center. Derrida says this determines how the structure of the text is built, which parts are included and which are excluded. So, when we analyze the structure of literature and discuss its meaning and effect, we attempt to identify and differentiate those elements responsible for that effect; we discard the potential patterns that do not produce that effect. Thus, this center is the starting point for understanding the structure. But it also limits the analysis. Because the center creates hierarchies to stabilize itself and controls them. And this pre-knowledge of meaning also depends on the text's prior history and contemporary critical theory and ideology. If these are all part of culture, then how can we keep them separate from the structure, which they limit, but why should we ourselves not be limited by them? Making the basis of your analysis a fixed center is like providing a recipe, and this is a reactionary or status quo position. And from this, the desire to extract standard and incomparable independent meaning is proven false. So, the illusion that we are seeing the structure is an illusion; in reality, you are constructing the structure from the textual material.

Thus, even in Derrida's post-structuralism, it is impossible to start without a center, but through the deconstructive analysis of that unproven self-evident fact, he replaces that center with another center, but this new center is also not permanent.

Similarly, Saussure, in his theory of the sign, analyzes the sign: a word like 'cat' is 'cat' because it is not something else. So, the word is the signifier, and what it denotes is the signified/ object. But Derrida says you first need to bring a concept. And if you make the signifier absolute, claiming it has no relation to any signified, that it is an independent concept in itself, with no direct relation to any signified/object, then this concept transcends all signifiers and signifies nothing. And if we consider the signifier and signified as identical, it challenges the very basis of the signifier.

So, Saussure's theory is opposed to logic-based reasoning when he says you do not see any characteristic of the signified in the signifier. But when he says the signifier is merely used to denote the signified and is therefore subordinate to it, he appears to support a logic-based theory. So Derrida says this clear distinction between signified and signifier is not valid, and the priority given to signified over signifier should also be abandoned.

Meaning does not pre-exist in the signifier. And complete meaning is not found in a single signifier. So, you have to delve deep into the text, and this drives you towards an endless search. Thus, the signifier determines the signified based on its difference from other signifiers; the more difference, the closer you are to the signified. But you can never capture all the differences. However, there must be repetition in the signifier, even when one signifier determines a different signified. And for this, knowing the written history of that signifier is necessary. So, the signifier gives different meanings and sometimes even opposite meanings.

Plato: Plato says no art can be good because it is all false and unreal. Plato's idea should also be seen as a reaction to the military inferiority of Athens compared to Sparta.

Derrida writes that from Plato to Saussure and Levi-Strauss, everyone prioritized speech over writing, because writing is a medium; the real thing is speech. Saussure focuses on pronunciation errors in the written form. But Derrida says the characteristics present in speech are also present in writing. Furthermore, he says the effacement of the signified creates the illusion of the direct presence of thought in speech. But if we record spoken words and listen, it is also a chain of signifiers like written words, in which different signifiers can be identified by their differences from each other. And writing can also be of two types: ordinary writing and writing done through understanding or pictographic writing. Behind all this is the 'metaphysics of presence'. The 'metaphysics of presence' in Western philosophy, the core of which is immediate experience—but deconstruction says there is no such experience at a meta-linguistic level, because this experience is identified through the medium of language. And then, the idea that we understand ultimate truth through divine consciousness—deconstruction says this is merely a creation of the creator. And also, the notion that truth is hidden behind an object—deconstruction says no such independent existence exists; everything is created and recreated by the system. So, Saussure's self-presence is nothing, because everything is constructed within a system.

Derrida says that logic is the basis of all these philosophical thoughts; an ultimate truth and universal self is hypothesized, which is omniscient. But Derrida says this unproven center has been called God at times, Idea at times, and Universal Self at times, and it created different levels below itself. So, religion considered God as the ultimate truth, and humans and other creations as incomplete and opposed; and all these became centers that claimed to create a system of thought in their own way. But they must be above the system. So, God must exist independently outside religion. Post-structuralist deconstruction considers the existence of such a meta-truth as virtual, and post-structuralists consider it the result of a theory of language. Thus, in the interplay of these signifiers, some meaning achieves a higher status due to the intervention of some ideology, and its other meaning is pushed behind it. Ideologies like freedom, democracy, justice are part of our lives, but it seems that many meanings of our lives have been derived from them, but upon investigation, they turn out to be derived from other ideas. There is no concept that does not contain traces of other ideas.

In response to "gaslighting," Story Science emerges. It pre-analyzes based on the impact of hearing a story on people and society. Story Science also says that the one who tells the story rules, and the more stories one tells, the further ahead one goes.

"He who listens to the story rules this world"—Hopi American Indian proverb.

Indian Concept of Poetry: The concept of art for the purpose of liberation (moksha), as seen in the Nataraja's posture. The rhythm of creation and destruction is visible. The permanent emotion (sthayibhava) deepens, matures, and becomes rasa (essence)—and thus, many rasas were experienced by Sita and Ram (see Valmiki Ramayana). Krishna is the teacher of Indian karma (action) and also a connoisseur (rasika). For the enjoyment of art, the concept of Rasa became necessary, and Bharata wrote the Natya Shastra. Abhinavagupta wrote a commentary on Anandavardhana's Dhvanyaloka. Bhamaha (6th century), Dandi (7th century), and Rudrata (9th century) advanced it further. Rasa Theory: Bharata: Rasa is produced from the effect of drama. What is drama for? Drama is for the enactment of rasa and also for the production of rasa. How does rasa emerge? Rasa emerges from the determinants (vibhava), consequences (anubhava), and accompanying elements (vyabhichari). The permanent emotion deepens, matures, and becomes rasa, whose essence we can taste. Bhatta Lollata: The permanent emotion, through cause and effect, becomes rasa. Actors and actresses experience rasa through practice and imagination. Lollata does not give importance to the poet or the listener/viewer. Shounaka: Shounaka believes that to experience rasa, the viewer must immerse themselves in the performance, like understanding the essence of a horse by seeing it as a horse from its picture. Bhatta Nayaka says the effect of rasa is on the viewer. He considers the poet's language to be special. Rasa unites the soul of the listener/viewer with the Supreme Soul. The bliss of rasa is the bliss of one's own nature. And this leads to self-realization. Rasa theory is based on the listener/viewer/reader. It emphasizes the listener/viewer/reader.

Dhvani Theory: Anandavardhana's Dhvanyaloka—the purpose of literature is to suggest meaning indirectly or to produce meaning. This theory provides the structure and function of indirect meaning, the experience of beauty (rasa), and the theory of figures of speech (alankara). Anandavardhana considers dhvani (suggestion) as the soul of poetry. Through dhvani, meaning comes indirectly,

but it comes in a well-organized manner. And from this, two theories emerge: meaning and symbol. From this, the effect of rasa is produced. Nyaya and Mimamsa opposed this theory; both philosophies say that dhvani does not exist anywhere; it is a result of inference and already falls under the category of indication. And not everything can be described by words.

Sphoṭa Theory: Bhartrihari's Vakyapadiya says that the meaning of a word or sentence is conveyed by sphoṭa (the linguistic unit). From varṇa-sphoṭa, the phoneme; from pada-sphoṭa, the word; and from vakya-sphoṭa, the sentence is constructed. No knowledge is possible without the connection of the word. This became a part of the epistemology of Indian philosophy. The transmission of meaning is possible without the origin of the letter, word, and sentence. Sphoṭa is the Word-Brahman and is the root cause of creation. The letter, word, and sentence do not exist simultaneously. The separate letters in spoken words do not contain the meaning of the word; their origin and destruction continue until the word is complete. In sphoṭa, meaning is transmitted, but even then, at the time of realization or the moment of communication, the letter, word, or sentence did not exist. Until the word is complete, each successive letter becomes meaningful, and until the sentence is complete, each successive word becomes meaningful. Samkhya, Nyaya, Vaisheshika, Mimamsa, and Vedanta—all these philosophies do not accept sphoṭa. These philosophies believe that letters and their sounds adequately complete the meaning. France's Jacques Derrida's theory of deconstruction and dissemination is close to the sphoṭa theory.

Alankara Theory: Bhamaha calls alankara (figures of speech) as 'samasokti', which causes delight. Dandi and Udbhata also advanced the theory of alankara. There are fundamentally two types of alankara: based on word and based on meaning. Further classifications are based on similarity-opposition, logic, folk logic, poetic logic, and suggestion of deeper meaning. Mammata divides 61 types of alankara into 7 parts: Upama (simile), Rupaka (metaphor), Aprastuta (indirect praise), Dipaka (shared illumination), Vyatireka (contrast), Virodha (opposition), and Samucchaya (accumulation).

Aucitya Theory: Kshemendra, in his discussion of propriety (aucitya), considered it the main element of literature. And where should propriety exist? It should exist in pada (word), vakya (sentence), the meaning of the

composition (prabandha), guna (qualities), alankara, rasa, karaka (agent), kriya (action), linga (gender), vachana (number), visheshana (qualifier), upasarga (prefix), nipata (particle), kala (time), desha (place), kula (lineage), vrata (vow), tattva (principle), satva (inner nature), abhipraya (intention), svabhava (nature), sara-sangraha (essence collection), pratibha (genius), avastha (condition), vichara (thought), nama (name), and ashirvada (blessing).

Tom Stoppard's radio play "In the Native State" and his subsequent play "Indian Ink" based on it discuss the Rasa theory in detail. John Cage's "Sonatas and Interludes" also contains melodies based on the Rasa theory. Additionally, Richa Biswal wrote "Analysis of John Donne's Poetry in the Light of Bharata's Rasa-Theory," published by Kavikulguru Kalidas Sanskrit University, Ramtek.

Sushil wrote four books: two novels, one play, and one short story collection. Ramlochan Thakur writes in the introduction to Asmitā: "He has written many stories, but publishing all of them in book form was not possible."

In both novels, I felt that the novelist Sushil was under pressure to write concisely, but he didn't seem tired. 'Asmitā', 'Bhokaṭa', and 'Asal Bāt Jaṛiāoṭhā' seemed like three weak stories; perhaps the story writer was tired. But was the writer tired, or was he made to feel tired? The pseudocriticism in Maithili killed him. In his story 'Ekta Kalakar Ki Atmahatyā', when the artist gave up art, it was a suicide; but if others are responsible for it, and he gave up writing stories, novels, and plays, then it was a murder.

In his novel, Sushil sketches a picture of a specific time and place. For example, Gharāṛī (novel) (1973) begins on the veranda of the village house, describing what was kept on the veranda and the view in front of it. Then enters Ratan, a military man, whose share of land has been plowed. The conflict between the village and the outside world begins. The attachment to the ancestral land; Lalbabu is ready to exchange it, even offering two kathas extra, but Ratan does not exchange; why would he uproot himself and go elsewhere? Someone born in a city might find it hard to understand the attachment to ancestral land. For the sake of the land, Ratan's younger brother Mahadev is murdered, and Ratan is accused. He goes into hiding. Then, twists and turns. The story begins with the Brahmin Dr. Binayak and the Mallah nurse Karuna. Karuna says this

marriage is impossible; she is of low caste, a Mallah's daughter, and Binayak is a big man. But she too has love. Binayak thinks Karuna is a coward. But the novelist introduces an old man with a stick into his dream, who tells Binayak that the one whom Binayak considers strong is actually weak due to the suffocating norms of society.

Meanwhile, Ratan is under the protection of his friend Avadhesh, a devotee of Lord Shiva. He goes to the Bhootnath temple at Nimtala Ghat to seek refuge with Lord Shiva. He meets Avadhesh, who lives with his wife Sunita on Bhupen Bose Avenue.

From the village to the city, the novelist's description now moves in another direction.

There is a warrant against Ratan. Then back from the city to the village. What was the matter that the Mallahs and Lalbabu understood?

He meets Shéfali with Avadhesh. During the conversation, Shéfali says Avadhesh gave jobs to many Maithils, but they all keep criticizing him. Shéfali says her uncle is a lawyer; he says Ratan will win, but the real murderer must also be found. Ratan believes the real murderer is Lalbabu's henchman, Paragas. Shéfali's father, Rai Ji, is Maithil, and her mother is Bengali. So, in the city, love marriage had already occurred a generation earlier.

Lalbabu tries to get rid of Karuna through Paragas. Paragas goes with four men, but Karuna fights back fiercely and frees herself. If they get Karuna and Paragas married, the matter will be settled. He returns home.

Then, the description of the city. Thanks to Mr. Rai, Ratan got a job and bail. Lalbabu asks Paragas to play his final role.

The final section is seventeen. The day of Durga Visarjan (immersion). For Durga Puja, three plays are staged: two in Maithili and one in Hindi. Language discourse had already arrived by those days. The revelation of secrets and repentance. And the drama of Vijayadashami ends.

So, what did the Maithili literature reader gain from the novel Gharāṛī, and what did Maithili literature gain?

For the reader of Maithili literature, the experience of a time-machine along with a space-machine. By 1973, Hindi plays had already arrived in Mithila. Fathers did not accept inter-caste marriage, but mothers did. Murder even happened for ancestral land and property. People from Mithila in Kolkata had inter-caste marriages a generation earlier. One class had education, but the other class was discouraged; land was given for farming but without registration. The wealthy had chests on their verandas and bulls at their gates. Things were different in Calcutta (now Kolkata). But there too, those who got Maithils jobs would still complain about them.

Gāmbālī (novel) (1982) moves a step ahead. In Gharāṛī, it was revealed later that the girl was not a Mallah but a Brahmin. But in Gāmbālī, the novelist did not need to do that. He now introduces live-in relationships, children born from them, their acceptance in the village, the progressive thinking of the educated—all these are brought in. The era of black-and-white TV was there; on November 19, 1982, the Asian Games inauguration took place in India, and from that day, Doordarshan began color TV broadcasts. The situation is different from Gharāṛī's Lalbabu; here, the landlord is Sonmani Jha. He is walking step by step, meaning the end of zamindari is understood. Gāmbālī's funeral rites are performed by the Yadav society together. There are Goar Toli, Babhan Toli, Kayasth Toli, Jolaha Toli. Gāmbālī's husband was old; that is child marriage. She was his third wife; that is polygamy. The Hindu Marriage Act was enacted in 1955, but in the novel published in 1982 about a Mithila village, it is not in effect; it might have been in the city's VIP areas. After Gāmbālī's death today, she has no shortage of admirers. She came with pride and left with pride. Times were changing. Gyanchan was a lover of songs. He was very fond of foreign dances and nautanki (folk theatre), which was considered an art form for the young, but the noble and the new-generation gentlemen would sit in the front. He knew all the songs of the foreign dance by heart. He could sing Vidyapati and Nirgun Nacari in the same way, which pleased the Brahmins; his village was a Brahmin village. He also remembered the bhajans of Mira and Kabir. But for the songs and dances of Jalim Singh, his mind would race, he would feel hesitant, but he didn't dare. But now, in the village, the village Sushil describes,

many things have changed. Most dance parties have stopped; those that remain are struggling. Gyanchan's harmonium, watch, and horse came from the Sonpur Mela. The Sonpur Mela still happens, but harmoniums and watches are sold year-round in nearby towns. Gyanchan's harmonium, watch, and horse caught some people's eyes. But in today's era, that is no concern for anyone. There are occasional incidents in a year where, during a wedding procession, people from outside Mithila, like from Uttar Pradesh, come riding horses and stones are thrown at the procession. Then, there is talk about some child widows in the village. And Gyanchan becomes thoughtful: will Gāmbālī also become like Kiran Dai one day? If not Kiran Dai, she would become a Sakele. If not that, she would become a Parmeshwari. If not that, she would become a Ratni. But Ratni fell. No, Gāmbālī wouldn't become anything. She is invincible. She would never give in. Much improvement may not have happened yet, but many people stand in favor of both divorce and widow remarriage. Divorce, remarriage, widow remarriage, and inter-caste marriages are happening a lot. When inter-caste marriages happened a few years ago, one had to treat the whole village to rasgullas, but now that is not the case; even those who used to oppose it, their children are now freely doing inter-caste marriages. Sonmani thought: Gyanchan is in everyone's heart, including his own. But when he started to weigh Gyanchan, he couldn't find a single grain of hope. Meaning, the arrogance still exists. Gyanchan's marriage happened by a certain measure—that's how it is in youth. There's an engagement between us, maybe it will happen somewhere—Gyanchan says. Then the novelist talks about Gāmbālī's parental home and society.

Gyanchan opened a middle school in the village on the bullock's back. He also got the road leveled.

After Gāmbālī's death, her son is fifteen years old. For the funeral pyre, seven men are needed. The word spreads: Ramadhar's son, then Baiju's son, and then others start joining. Bamboo is being cut from the 'Jhagraua Beat'. The trees Gyanchan had planted have now become someone else's. The funeral rites are performed there. The library will be named 'Gāmbālī Smarak Pustakalaya' (Gāmbālī Memorial Library).

So, what did the Maithili literature reader gain from the novel Gāmbālī, and what did Maithili literature gain?

The novel Gāmbālī was a revolutionary novel of its era. Society was changing. A writer should be ahead of society, but the mainstream Maithili writers are behind society. So, they marginalized Sushil. You can read the novel Gāmbālī in one sitting. This novel is a documentary; a picture of society, child widows, arrogance, and struggle comes to the fore.

Bhāmatī (Drama) (First staging 1991, Publication 2013)

The elderly Vachaspati was inclusive, so the Vachaspati in the play does not match him. There is feminist discourse in Shambhavi's character, but not in Bhāmatī's character. Despite these two shortcomings, the play Bhāmatī holds the highest position in the category of Maithili historical plays and resists mainstream slapstick drama. The use of the "Oedipus," "Electra," and "Castration" complexes, used to analyze sexual behavior, can also be used to explain the greed of society. The vulturous gaze of society did not spare Bhāmatī either. The inclusion of this in the play and the description of the capacity for women to resist it—both these facts make Sushil more courageous and distinctive than mainstream playwrights.

Asmitā (Short Story Collection) (2016)

'Baghotiya' demonstrates how fake news is spread, and Bihari is brought in and then disappears. The story progresses with remarkable ease and skill. In stories like 'My Latest Photograph', 'Prem-Prasang', 'Prem Ne Baḍi Upajay', 'Pipani Par Nor', 'Pusht.. Pusht.. Pusht', 'Ekta Kalakar Ki Atmahatyā', 'Gharmaṅhā', and 'Sanakirbā', all elements of the modern short story are present. These stories contain hints of all contemporary issues, whether it is terrorism or fake encounters. 'Gām Sadhbā Hoit Achhi' and 'Asmitā' are stories of feminist discourse. In 'Gām Sadhbā Hoit Achhi', there is feminist discourse, and the idea of accompanying one's husband and son within it is a resistance by Sushil against the mainstream. The character of Praveer's mother is the strongest.

'Bhokaṭa' is the story of the widow Savitri and Mantor.

'Asal Bāt Jaṛiāoṭhā' is about the politics of profit and the politics of shops with private tutoring services.

In 'Bāt Tākait Ekta Sehantā', the buffalo's application was approved; the condition of schools is the same across the country, so how could that be right?

In 'Mātsarya', the story skillfully portrays the narrator's mental state.

'Vigyāpan Karāmāt' is about the magic of advertising.

'Masjid': Devkant's guru has to go far to offer namaz. Devkant decides to build a mosque in the village for his guru, with everyone's cooperation.

'Haḍtāl': Bhola passed matriculation. He opened a tea shop. Today there is a strike. A pipe gun bullet hits him; he dies.

'Sadak': A road is being built in the village. Sukru could open a tea shop. There is great shame in keeping buffaloes; some say it's a 'Naath Kasu' issue, people grab onto caste. But Lambodar Babu... the road doesn't get built. Well, half a life has already passed.

'Katahu Nahi': The village seems new, like a different village. Chhote Babu had passed away; he had told Pritam two days ago to be present on the 15th of August, but Pritam had gone off somewhere with some sister yesterday. He would understand everything here; such things are not hidden. The body shivered.

'Sabta Rehal-Khehal': The ten cars, gossip, then a robbery. Then the R.P.F. arrives. These passengers come once or twice a year; the ten cars are all ruined.

Sushil's modernity lies in the fact that he brings forth both the good and bad aspects of the city and the village. He is neither modern nor ancient, nor is he enamored by new things or ideologies. Sushil's modernity is inclusive; it

believes in taking something from one ideology and giving something else, and it does not believe in covering up or hiding mistakes, even in the name of ideology. Therefore, mainstream pseudocritics like Gangesh commit honor killing on him. And as we are concluding this book, the situation has not changed, and we have to write an editorial like this in issue 397 of Videha.

117, Sagar Raati Deep Jare, Darbhanga (Organizers: Hirendra Jha and Ashok Kumar Mehta)

The gaze of the then-chairperson of the Sahitya Akademi's Maithili Advisory Committee (now former), Ashok Avichal, fell on 'Sagar Raati Deep Jare', and in an attempt to destroy it, Hirendra Jha became a willing victim of blackmailing. He committed the crime of tampering with numbers, even counting the programs of a Delhi-based organization organized during Tagore's 150th birth anniversary year for the Sahitya Akademi, which he considers cleverness. Such tendencies have been observed in people after becoming the chairperson of the Maithili Advisory Committee. Victims include Ramdev Jha, known for his research; Chandranath Mishra Amar, whose contributions to the first phase of the movement were covered up; and now an eclipse has fallen on Nachiketa. Hirendra Jha has done this misdeed for the third time; this time, Kamal Mohan Jha or Mishra Chunoo also joined him. Yes, the co-organizer Ashok Kumar Mehta did not join him in this misdeed.

What happened?

In a pre-planned conspiracy, to which Ashok Avichal's contribution is described above, Hirendra Jha was made the co-organizer of 'Sagar Raati Deep Jare' (clearly told not to tamper with the numbers), and Kamal Mohan Jha or Mishra Chunoo were kept ready. But every theft leaves a clue. The chairperson, in a hurry without any proposal, declared that the next conference would be in Patna, and the one after that in Delhi (where the Sahitya Akademi's headquarters are), and then he corrected himself, saying the decision (about the Delhi one) would be made in Patna. Kamal Mohan Jha or Mishra Chunoo were ready; they immediately took the registration book and lamp from Hirendra Jha and tried to smile shamelessly (but they seem like objects of humor, not even laughter). They got their pictures taken.

What should be the response?

This is Hirendra Jha's third mistake in this series; he should be banned from three 'Sagar Raati' events. This is Kamal Mohan Jha or Mishra Chunoo's first mistake; they should be banned from one 'Sagar Raati' event. The majority of the people present were waiting for the 118th 'Sagar Raati' organizers. The next 'Sagar Raati' number should be 118, and it should be publicized so that the chairperson of the Sahitya Akademi's Maithili Advisory Committee would think twice before doing such a deed.

Misdeeds of the New Sahitya Akademi Maithili Advisory Committee Chairperson and Members

For their own publicity, the new Sahitya Akademi Maithili Advisory Committee recited this shloka for the old committee:

Yada yada hi dharmasya glanirbhavati Bharata

Abhyutthanam adharmasya tadatmanam srijamyaham ||4.7||

(Bhagavad Gita)

Whenever there is a decline in righteousness and a rise in unrighteousness, O Bharata, then I manifest myself. And so much unrighteousness occurred that Nachiketa and his team took an avatar.

And what did they do?

Within a month, in the first meeting itself, the distribution of monographs, translations, etc., was done, and the team members distributed all the assignments among themselves, their cronies, and followers. Nachiketaji kept watching, even cooperating. The score for the parallel stream was zero anyway; the avataric people kept it at zero.

Politics of Awards

Narayanji wrote 'Anar' instead of 'Daarim' and he is not a children's writer; he wrote children's literature to get an award. Munni Kamat's 'Chukka' is available in the Videha Petar. Narayanji should read that book and decide if his book stands up to it. And if they have no conscience, then they should shamelessly take awards like Hirendra Jha/Kamal Mohan Jha or Mishra Chunoo—our best wishes. And if they don't listen to their conscience, they should come out of the quagmire. [Videha Issue 397 Editorial]

[Both Michel Foucault's "Disciplinary Institution" and the psychological concept of "gaslighting" by Barton and Whitehead have the same target. Foucault's "Disciplinary Institution" is about bringing the targeted person into discipline, pitting everyone against each other, rewarding some, and gradually poisoning those who do not comply. In gaslighting, the target is made to believe that their opposition to the status quo is not opposition, that everyone is doing it, and that they are just opposing for the sake of opposition to hide their own shortcomings. It also takes help from the basic shortcomings present in society, and gradually the target becomes disgraced or flees.

All of Foucault's disciplinary institutions, like the Sahitya Akademi, Maithili Akademi, Maithili Bhojpuri Akademi, and the so-called literary associations recognized by the Sahitya Akademi, are with the mainstream. Attempts have been made for a long time to bring 'Sagar Raati Deep Jare' under Foucault's defined disciplinary institution.]

There is no melodrama in Sushil's plays, stories, or novels. Where there is a happy ending, there is no melodrama; where there is a sad ending, there is no melodrama either; there is satire. Like in the story 'Sadak': "Well, half a life has already passed." Like in the story 'Haḍtāl': "A pipe gun bullet hits him; he dies. In the evening, a silent procession is taken out in his mourning."

Thus, Sushil's work is not based on any rasa theory; it contains contemporary concerns; even in historical plays, contemporary social discourse is embedded. So, Sushil did not need the cloak of Marxism, yet he wrote the story 'Haḍtāl'. Sushil is concerned about the growing communal atmosphere in the country,

which he brings out in the end of the story 'Masjid'. He is conscious of culture and language. He is conscious of change. He is conscious of nature on all four sides, as seen in 'Baghotiya' and also in his novels. But humans are at his center.

## Chapter 2

## Post-Theory

After post-deconstruction, post-theory emerged.

Formalism began in Russia in the early 20th century. They rejected the belief that literary creation is an expression of the author's worldview; rather, they believed it is a system governed by rules. For them, craft and form were more important than subject matter. They did not accept the notions that literature is written based on psychological criticism, the author's biography, or experienced reality. They criticized a scientific approach to literature and believed that literary language is different from ordinary language; it has a separate, independent existence, and its analysis should be done independently, not based on what happened in the author's life, nor on psychoanalysis like Hamlet hesitates to kill his uncle but not others because he wanted to kill his father himself and killing his uncle seems like killing himself (Freud). Analysis should be based on the actual text of literary language.

France's Albert Camus (1942) calls those who wander holding onto faith amidst the absurdity of life, where crisis and illusion are everywhere, as committing "philosophical suicide." In Sushil's literature, you will never find such philosophical suicide by Sushil, not even in 'Ekta Kalakar Ki Atmahatyā'.

French philosopher Roland Barthes (1967) calls the situation after the creation of literature the "death of the author," and says the text is determined not by the author's intention but by how the reader interprets it.

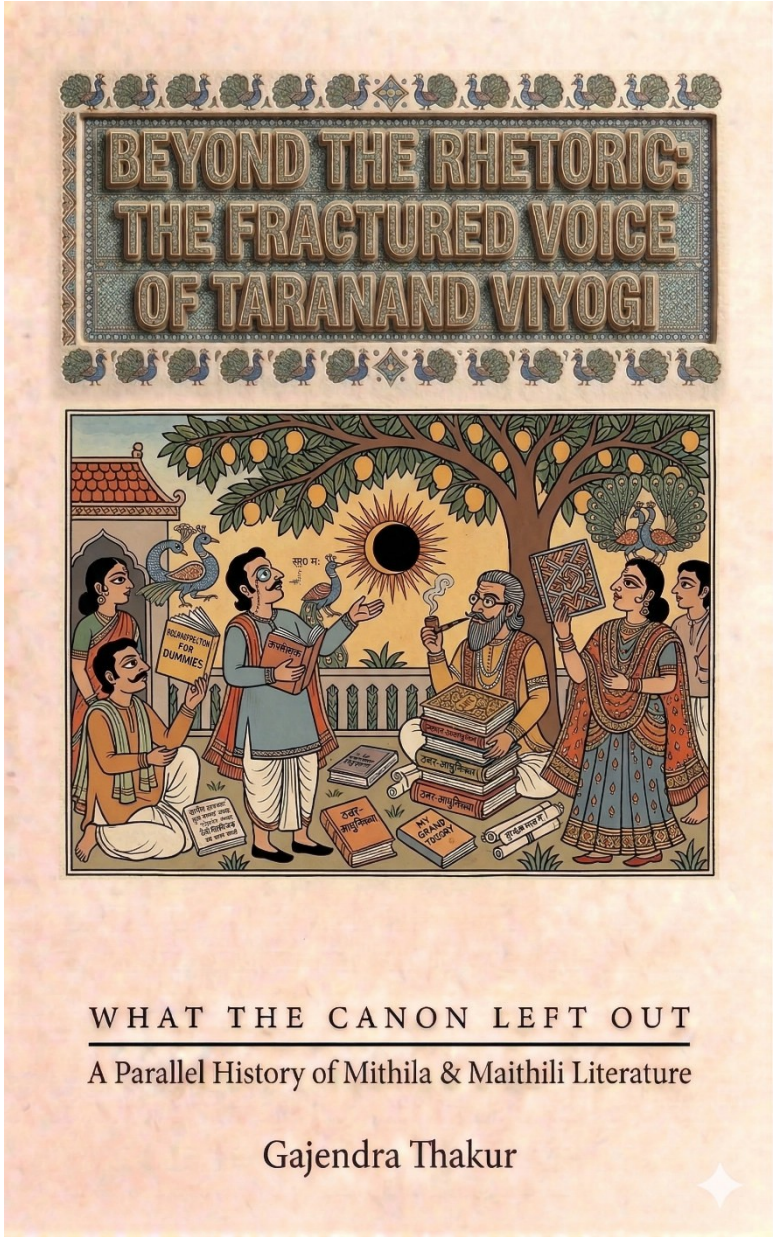
Francis Fukuyama (1992) says that Western liberal democracy is the final form of evolution emerging from the struggle of opposing ideologies (like

communism and democracy), and since there is now only one ideology, it is the end of history.

Some works please a reader, others do not; thus, literary criticism is done by the reader, not by any school. New theories are just new versions of old ones, remixing and repackaging old theories. The text of the work is the only important thing; no theory is needed for it. Thus, post-theory has moved towards the perspectives of logical positivism and new logical positivism.

A critique of Sushil's work has been possible through this post-theory, although the relevance of feminism and psychoanalytic analysis has also aligned with post-theory.

**LESSON 089 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**



# Beyond the Rhetoric: The Fractured Voice of Taranand Viyogi

**Abstract:**
Taranand Viyogi (b. 1966) is the most versatile Maithili writer of his generation, yet his work is deeply contested. While presenting himself as a champion of Dalit aesthetics, critics argue his methods constitute a "Neo-Brahminical" project. This monograph provides a comprehensive analysis of Viyogi's entire corpus—poetry, ghazal, fiction, criticism, and history—using Indian aesthetics (Rasa, Dhvani, Navya-Nyāya), Western theory (Marx, Foucault, Spivak), and the Videha Parallel History Framework.

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### 1. Preface and Methodological Framework

Taranand Viyogi stands as one of the most intellectually formidable and socially committed writers in contemporary Maithili literature. With nearly forty published titles across poetry, ghazal, fiction, criticism, and history, he is arguably the most versatile Maithili writer of his generation. Yet his significance is matched by intense controversy.

This monograph applies a **pluralist critical methodology**:

- **Indian Classical Aesthetics:** Rasa (Bharata), Dhvani (Ānandavardhana), Vakrokti (Kuntaka).
- **Navya-Nyāya Epistemology:** The *pramāṇa* framework of Gaṅgeśa (pratyakṣa, anumāna, śabda).
- **Western Critical Traditions:** Aristotle, Marx, Gramsci, Spivak (Subaltern), Foucault, Iser.
- **Videha Parallel History Framework:** Gajendra Thakur’s anti-establishment revisionist historiography.
- **Maithili-Specific Debates:** The applicability of Urdu-Persian *bahar* prosody to the Maithili ghazal.

### 2. Biographical Profile: Displacement and Institutional Power

Viyogi’s life is defined by a paradoxical trajectory from the margins of society to the center of state power.

- **Origins & Displacement:** Born in 1966 in Mahishi, Saharsa, into a family of agricultural laborers uprooted by the Sapta Kosi High Dam. This "ur-condition" of displacement infuses his work.
- **Education & Career:** Educated in the Sanskrit high school tradition (PhD, Sahityācharya). He serves as a Bihar Administrative Service officer (Deputy Collector, CEO).
- **Literary Lineage:** He positions himself as the heir to Nagarjun (Yatri) and Rajkamal Chaudhary. His credo: *"Yatri made Maithili sweat... dragged it out of silken salons into sunburnt soil."*
- **Public Controversy:** His poem *'Bābhanak Gāam'* (2000) incited a Brahmin poet-friend to distribute copies hoping to provoke violence against Viyogi.

**3. Complete Works: Annotated Bibliography**

| Genre | Key Titles | Critical Assessment |
|---|---|---|
| **Poetry** | *Hastkṣep* (1996), *Sākhi* (2020), *Pralaya Rahasya*, *Dharāśāyī Hebāk Samay* (2021) | Uses folk forms (Kabir *sākhi*) to document caste violence and the COVID-19 crisis. |
| **Ghazal** | *Apan Yudhak Sākṣya* (1991/2017) | Insists on strict Urdu-Persian *bahar* (meter), claiming the form as a "combative platform." |
| **Short Fiction** | *Atikramaṇ* (1997), *Chiyānat* (2020) | Explores the globalizing millennial moment and its effects on rural Bihar. |
| **Biography** | *Tumi Chir Sārathi* (2016), *Yugon Kā Yātrī* | Explores the life of Nagarjun, positioning him as the "eternal charioteer" of Maithili. |
| **Criticis** | *Bahuvachan* (2015), *Karmadhar* | A major survey of |

| Genre | Key Titles | Critical Assessment |
|---|---|---|
| **m** | *ay* | modern Maithili literature through the lens of *navjāgaraṇa* (renaissance). |
| **History** | *Maithilī Kavitak Hazar Varṣa* (2 vols) | A monumental attempt to recover "history-excluded poets" (*itihāsa-vañcit kavī*). |

**4. Theoretical Frameworks Applied**

**A. Indian Poetics (Rasa, Dhvani, Vakrokti)**

- **Rasa:** Viyogi's Dalit poetry fuses *raudra* (fury) and *karuṇa* (pathos), refusing resolution into *śānta* (tranquility)—a political refusal of upper-caste transcendence.
- **Dhvani:** The title *Apan Yudhak Sākṣya* operates on multiple levels: testimony (*sākṣya*) and war (*yuddha*), echoing both legal epistemology and the Gita.
- **Vakrokti:** His "oblique" use of mythological terms (e.g., *pralaya* as social destruction) produces aesthetic surprise.

**B. Western Critical Theory**

- **Gramsci & Spivak:** Viyogi challenges Brahminical cultural hegemony. However, his claim to speak for Dalits as an OBC writer risks "strategic essentialism" that silences the subaltern.
- **Foucault (Author-Function):** Viyogi operates as a "transdiscursive" author. His name signifies authority even when his work lacks evidence, constructed by institutional "monastery heads."
- **Wolfgang Iser (Act of Reading):** Viyogi fails the primary act of reading (e.g., misreading Dhumketu's story), violating the phenomenology of aesthetic response.

**C. Navya-Nyāya Epistemology (Gaṅgeśa)**

- **Pakṣatā (Supposition):** Every Viyogi poem presents a thesis (e.g., "Caste harms the oppressor").

- **Śabda-pramāṇa (Testimony):** Viyogi uses oral tradition as valid evidence, challenging scriptural bias.
- **The Critique:** Critics argue Viyogi fails *Pratyakṣa* (perception) by making claims without textual examples, and lacks *aparokṣa jñāna* (direct knowledge). He is an *apramāṇa* (unreliable) speaker.

**D. Videha Parallel History Framework**

- Developed by Gajendra Thakur, this framework argues Maithili history was shaped by Brahminical gatekeeping.
- **Viyogi's Role:** He provides the "living work" (creative literature) to Thakur's "archive."
- **The Counter-Argument:** Viyogi commits a "monohistorical fallacy"—believing his revisionist approach is the only truth, thus replicating exclusionary tactics.

**5. Creative Works: Poetry, Ghazal, and Fiction**

**A. The Dalit Intervention (*Hastkṣep, Sākhi*)**

- ***Hastkṣep* (1996):** The title ("Intervention") declares a disruption of the Brahminical status quo.
- ***'Bābhanak Gāam':*** Critiques how caste "deforms" Brahmin children. It extends compassion to the oppressor, an Ambedkarite move.
- ***Sākhi* (2020):** Invokes the Kabir tradition for Dalit testimony. Poems like *'Akādamī Meṃ Dalit'* attack institutional tokenism.

**B. Apocalypse and Love (*Pralaya Rahasya, Duniyā Ghar Mehman*)**

- ***Pralaya Rahasya:*** Repurposes Hindu cosmological dissolution as a metaphor for the destruction of feudal-caste structures.
- ***Duniyā Ghar Mehman:*** Claims the classical *śṛṅgāra* (love) tradition for the non-Brahmin writer, inflected with feminist self-consciousness.

**C. The COVID Diary (*Dharāśāyī Hebāk Samay*)**

A unique "COVID Diary" that captures the prostration of the state and the suffering of migrant laborers. The day-by-day structure creates a formal correlative for pandemic time.

**D. The Maithili Ghazal (*Apan Yudhak Sākṣya*)**

Viyogi is a founding theorist of the Maithili ghazal. He insists on strict adherence to Urdu-Persian *bahar* (meter), arguing that the discipline of the form produces the tautness necessary for political utterance.

**E. Short Fiction (*Atikramaṇ, Chiyānat*)**

The title *Chiyānat* (Betrayal) is programmatic. The stories focus on intimate betrayals by families and institutions during the globalizing millennial moment.

**6. Scholarly Works: Memoir, Criticism, and History**

**A. Memoir & Biography (*Tumi Chir Sārathi*)**

A celebrated memoir of Nagarjun. Viyogi argues that Nagarjun "rebuilt" Maithili by restoring the language to those it had been stolen from.

**B. Literary Criticism (*Bahuvachan*)**

- **Bahuvachan (Plural Form):** Argues for a multiplicity of voices against the "singular voice" of the Brahminical tradition.
- **Methodology:** Eclectic (Marxist, biographical, textual), reflecting his belief that no single method is adequate.

**C. Literary History (*Maithilī Kavitak Hazar Varṣa*)**

A monumental two-volume history supposedly trying to rehabilitate poets suppressed for their anti-Brahminical stances. He presents facts based on his pseudo assumptions which are factually wrong.

He wrongly claims that Maithili has a deep oral tradition preceding Sanskrit influence, a claim as unfounded as Rajeshwar Jha's argument that Brahmi script derives from Tirhuta (Mithilakshar). Yet even the Ṛgveda acknowledges the existence of parallel oral traditions like Narashanshi and Gāthā. Moreover, he ignores the presence of Chhanda in early Maithili literature, despite the fact that both the Ṛgveda and the Charyapada are composed in Chhanda. These oversights reveal his neo-brahminical bias.

**7. Critical Refutation: The Neo-Brahminical Paradox**

This section details the "Cons" argument: that Viyogi's methodology mirrors the gatekeeping he critiques.

**A. Institutional "Mathadheesh" Behavior**

Critics argue Viyogi has become a "mathadheesh" (monastery head) of Maithili criticism.

- **Exclusionary Tactics:** He practices *godhiyavad* (compromising criticism), protecting allies and erasing the names of rivals from literary histories.
- **Inauthentic Polemics:** His aggressive stance is the opposite of *sahṛdayatva* (empathetic resonance) required by Indian aesthetics.

**B. Epistemological Failures (Navya-Nyāya Refutation)**

Applying Gaṅgeśa's *Tattvacintāmaṇi*:

1. **Failure of Pratyakṣa (Perception):** Viyogi claims meter is not native to Maithili folk poetry but provides no textual scansions. Evidence from *Charyapad* (16 matras per line) contradicts him.
2. **Failure of Anumāna (Inference):** His argument that "Manbodh was the first to use meter" is based on a false example (*savyabhicāra*), making his inference invalid.
3. **Failure of Śabda (Testimony):** He is not an *āpta* (trustworthy) speaker. He evaluated Dhumketu's story *"Namaje Shukrana"* as communal harmony, but the story describes communal bigotry (a parrot thrown against a wall).

**C. The Meter Controversy**

- **Viyogi's Claim:** Meter is a "Sanskritic imposition" by a "parasitic priestly class."
- **The Refutation:** Meter exists in the *Charyapad* (8th-9th c.), the Malla kings' works, and saint poetry. Viyogi ignores these to maintain his polemic.

**8. Synthesis: Convergent Invalidity**

A multi-theoretical analysis reveals striking convergence:

- **Western Criticism (Iser/Fish):** Fails the act of reading; belongs to a "mythological criticism" community.
- **Indian Aesthetics (Abhinavagupta):** Lacks *sahṛdayatva*; confuses scribal error with authorial intention.
- **Videha Framework:** Commits the "monohistorical fallacy" (totalizing history).
- **Navya-Nyāya:** Claims are *apramāṇa* (not valid knowledge).

**Conclusion of the Refutation:** Viyogi's revisionist history often lapses into inauthentic scholarship. His work is not merely wrong; by Navya-Nyāya standards, it does not qualify as knowledge at all.

**9. Conclusion: The Burden of Authenticity**

**The Achievement:** Viyogi's corpus is the most comprehensive individual contribution to the democratization of Maithili literature. He has recovered suppressed voices, documented the pandemic's toll, and claimed a "plural" space for Maithili.

**The Paradox:** However, the "Neo-Brahminical" shift in his later work—assertion without evidence, erasure of dissent, refusal to engage with textual

reality—presents a profound contradiction. While he champions "resistance," his methodology mirrors the exclusionary gatekeeping he critiques.

**Final Verdict:** Taranand Viyogi remains a transformative yet deeply problematic figure. For Maithili literary studies to advance, it must move beyond such "mythological criticism" toward rigorous, evidence-based scholarship that meets the standards of *pramāṇa*.

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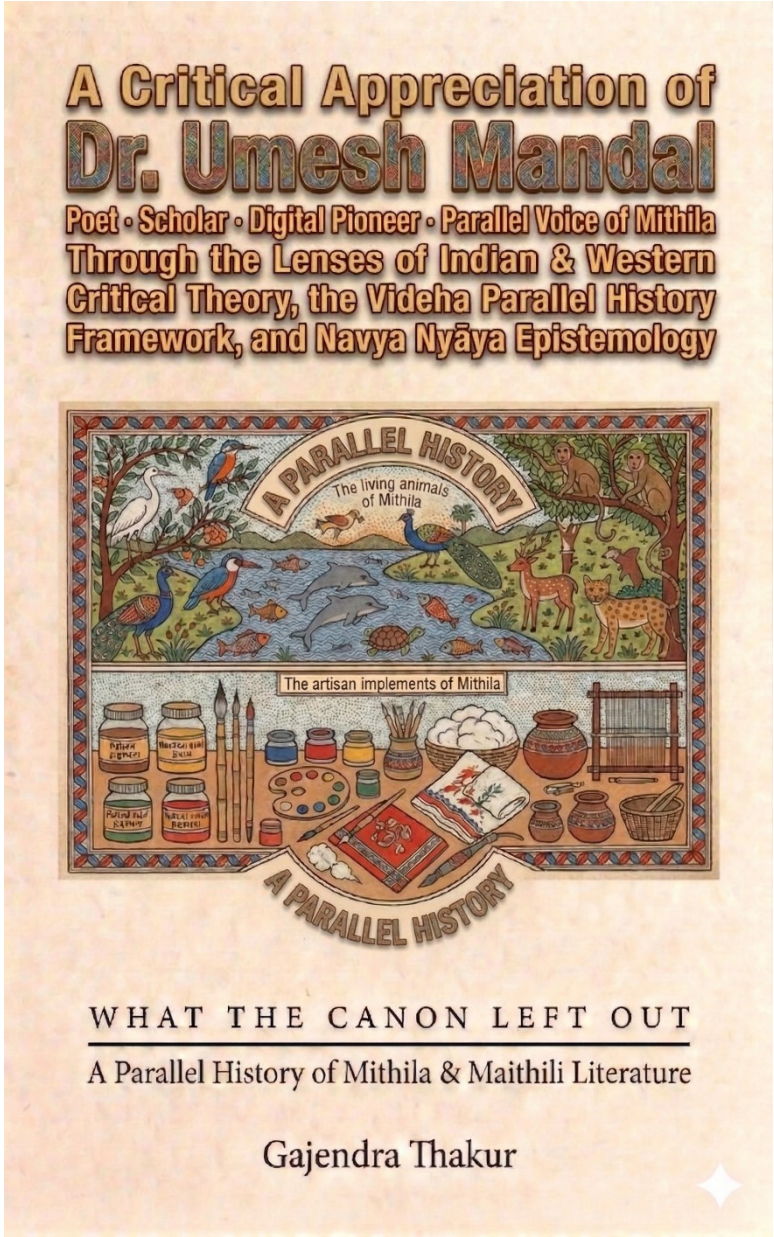
**LESSON 090 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**




## *A Critical Appreciation of*

**Dr. Umesh Mandal**

*Poet · Scholar · Digital Pioneer · Parallel Voice of Mithila*

Through the Lenses of Indian & Western Critical Theory, the Videha Parallel History Framework, and Navya Nyāya Epistemology

## Preface: The Act of Naming the Unnamed

The history of any literature is always, in part, a history of silences — of voices that spoke but were not heard, of texts that circulated but were not canonised. In the case of Maithili literature, that silence has been particularly structured: maintained, as the Videha Parallel History Framework meticulously documents, by the interlocking mechanisms of caste-based patronage, government academy capture, and the deliberate exclusion of writers from marginal communities.

Dr. Umesh Mandal — poet, literary critic, researcher, was co-editor of Videha, and one of the most industrious contributors to the Maithili digital project — is one of those voices. His poetry collection Nistuki (2009; 2nd ed. 2012) and his scholarly research monograph Jagdish Prasad Mandalak Kavya Sansar (2022) together constitute a double act of witness: the first bearing lyrical testimony to a world of migrating bodies, ecological grief, and social dislocation; the second performing the critical labour of recovering and illuminating another marginalised writer. This document is a critical appreciation of both contributions, approached through the intersecting lenses of Indian aesthetic theory (rasa-dhvani, aucitya), Western literary criticism (New Criticism, postcolonial theory, subaltern studies), the Videha Parallel History Framework, and the rigorous epistemological method of Navya Nyāya.

## I. Biographical and Socio-Cultural Context

Dr. Umesh Mandal was born and raised in Berma village, Madhubani district, Bihar — the heartland of the Mithila region. He completed a doctoral degree and earned a reputation as a multidimensional literary personality: poet, critic, editor, digital archivist, and language activist. His work is rooted in the specific agrarian, caste-marked, and ecologically vulnerable landscape of north Bihar, a region where the Kosi and Kamla rivers regularly assert their destructive sovereignty, where seasonal migration has become a defining demographic reality, and where the feudal residues of zamindari continue to structure social relations long after their legal abolition.

From the Videha Parallel History Framework's perspective, Umesh Mandal belongs to a generation of writers from 'backward caste' communities (OBC) who entered Maithili literature in the late twentieth century and fundamentally transformed its thematic and formal landscape. These writers — alongside Jagdish Prasad Mandal, Rajdeo Mandal, Ramdev Prasad Mandal 'Jharudar', and Sandeep Kumar Safi — are described by Gajendra Thakur (editor of Videha) as having 'pumped their energy, wealth, and time into our Maithili Language.'[1] Crucially, despite their significant literary and institutional contributions, none received Sahitya Akademi recognition: an RTI investigation by Vinit Utpal and Ashish Anchinhar (2011–14) revealed that over 90 per cent of all Sahitya Akademi assignments went to the friends, relatives, and associates of the ten-member Maithili advisory board.[2]

Umesh Mandal's specific contribution to the digital infrastructure of Maithili is extraordinary by any measure. Ashish Anchinhar records that Mandal developed more than 70 per cent of the content of Maithili Wikipedia.[3] As co-editor of Videha (ISSN 2229-547X), he was involved in the Google Translate and Wikipedia localisation drive for Maithili, the Tirhuta and Kaithi script research, the Braille localisation initiative, and the successful opposition to the misclassification of Maithili as a 'Bihari language.' His editorial work on Videha — acknowledged internationally when Gerard M linked Videha's Dasipat Aripan archive on his blog — signals the journal's reach beyond the South Asian literary conversation.

In addition to his role as digital archivist, Mandal is the author of the picture dictionary of Mithila's vegetation, animals, and craft skills — a lexicographic and ethnographic project that preserves ecological and material cultural knowledge at a moment of rapid environmental transformation. This breadth — from lyric poetry to scholarly criticism to lexicography to digital organisation — makes him a figure of unusual range and seriousness.

[1] Gajendra Thakur, 'A Parallel History of Mithila and Maithili Literature – Part 5', Videha, www.videha.co.in/new_page_5.htm

[2] Vinit Utpal / Ashish Anchinhar, RTI investigation (2011–14), cited in Gajendra Thakur, Parallel History Part 1, Videha.

[3] Ashish Anchinhar, Maithili Web Patrakaritak Itihas, cited in Mithilesh Kumar Jha, 'Maithili in the Digital Space', India Seminar 742 (2021).

# II. Nistuki (2009; 2nd ed. 2012): A Reading of the Poetry

## II.1 Textual Description and Formal Overview

Nistuki ('The Voiceless One' / 'One Bereft of Answer') is a collection of Maithili poems, short poems (laghu kavita), haiku/tanka sequences, and two ghazals. Published first by Shruti Prakashan (New Delhi, 2009) and reissued in a second edition (2012), the volume is typeset by Umesh Mandal himself — a small but telling detail, reflecting the self-reliant institutional stance of the parallel literary movement. The collection is internally diverse: it ranges from meditative verse on exile and landscape, to sharply political miniatures, to compressed lyric forms that test the genre boundaries of haiku and tanka within a Maithili matrix.

The table of contents is itself a map of the poet's concerns: Kumahi (the confused), Dharmma, Shubharambh (Auspicious Beginning), Munhathir (Threshold/Veranda), Pachmera, Khapra, Gamak Iyar (Village Friends), Paer Paduka (Sandals), Chhathi, Bhogi, Srota, Kalyani, Desh (Country), Aashcharya (Wonder), Bhasha Bhed (Language Difference), Nor (Tears/Light), Dharak Kat, Maral Buijh, Khushi (Happiness), Bat-Bataahi, He Yau Ah, Apan Gam (My Village), Kichhu Nai Furai (Nothing is Forgotten)... The thematic arc moves from individual consciousness to social critique, from the intimacy of the village threshold to the wide impersonality of national space.

## II.2 The Poetics of Exile: Padain, Threshold, and Ecological Loss

One of the most insistent presences in Nistuki is the figure of padain — migration, exile, departure. The reviewer's preface to the second edition captures the emotional charge: 'Mithilasañ padain bhai rahal chhai. Se rahi-rahi kachotai chhathi kavikañ' ('Migration from Mithila keeps happening. It gnaws at the poet, repeatedly'). The poems transform this sociological phenomenon — the outmigration of Maithil agricultural workers to Punjab, Delhi, and beyond — into a lyrical crisis. The village threshold (munhathir) itself becomes jungle; the familiar landscape of the gam is defamiliarised through absence.

In Navya Nyāya terms, one can speak of Mandal's poetry as performing a viśeṣya-viśeṣaṇa bhāva — a relational structure between the knowing subject (the displaced poet/witness) and the object of knowledge (the homeland in the process of being lost). The knowledge-event (jñāna) in the poem is never simple or unmediated; it is layered through inference (anumāna), through the

visible signs (liṅga) of absence — the overgrown threshold, the silenced wells, the fields without farmers. This epistemic complexity is what gives the poems their texture.

In Western critical terms, the poetry participates in what Raymond Williams called a 'structure of feeling' — a lived, affective relationship to the material conditions of a community in transition. The padain poems are not nostalgic in the regressive sense: they do not idealise the village that is being left. Rather, they register the loss structurally, understanding it as a consequence of the failure of agrarian political economy, of the gap between the promise of post-independence development and its delivery in the Mithila belt.

## II.3 Subaltern Consciousness and the Politics of the Lyric Voice

From a postcolonial and subaltern studies perspective — particularly in the wake of Spivak's reformulation of the question 'Can the Subaltern Speak?' — Mandal's poetry occupies a complex subject-position. As a writer from an OBC community, he writes from within Maithili literature while simultaneously contesting its canon. The very act of writing in Maithili — a language classified by the Indian state as a 'dialect of Hindi' for decades, despite the contrary findings of Grierson and Suniti Kumar Chatterjee[4] — is itself a political act. Mandal's poems participate in the ongoing collective claim for linguistic dignity.

Within the Parallel History Framework, Maithili literature from the Buddhist Charyapadas onward has carried a subterranean democratic tradition — voices from outside the Brahmin court, from farming and artisan communities, from women's oral practice. Mandal's poetry is a contemporary node in this tradition. His language is not the ornate Sanskrit-inflected Maithili of the classical court; it is closer to the spoken registers of rural Madhubani, rooted in material life — the khapra (broken tile/roof), the gam ka iyar (village companions), the paer paduka (sandals worn by the peasant-walker).

Applying Bakhtin's dialogic principle, one can read Nistuki as a site of heteroglossia — where the lyric 'I' carries the traces of multiple social voices, and where the poem's apparent interiority is always shadowed by the exterior pressures of caste, migration, and ecological collapse. The haiku and tanka sequences are particularly interesting in this regard: these forms, borrowed from the Japanese tradition but naturalised into Maithili, perform a kind of formal compression that enacts the poet's own situation — a voice attempting to preserve maximum meaning in minimum space, against the conditions of dispersal and loss.

## II.4 Rasa, Dhvani, and Aucitya: Indian Aesthetic Frameworks

Classical Indian aesthetics offers indispensable tools for reading Nistuki. The rasa theory of Bharata's Nāṭyaśāstra identifies nine primary emotional essences (navarasa) that literary art seeks to evoke. In Mandal's poetry, the dominant rasa is karuṇa (pathos, compassion) — the emotion evoked by separation, loss, and the suffering of living beings. This is not the sentimental karuṇa of Victorian elegies, but a karuṇa of witness: the poet sees the suffering of the departing migrant, the dry field, the abandoned threshold, and his seeing itself becomes a mode of ethical solidarity.

The dhvani theory of Ānandavardhana (9th century CE), as elaborated in the Dhvanyāloka, holds that the finest poetry operates through suggestion (vyañjanā) rather than through mere denotation (abhidhā) or metaphor (lakṣaṇā). The best lines in Nistuki operate precisely at this dhvani level: what the poem 'says' is the surface of a deeper resonance. The 'threshold gone to jungle' does not merely describe an overgrown verandah; it suggests the collapse of domestic community, the end of intergenerational dwelling, the erasure of the social geography by which Maithil identity has been reproduced. This is dhvani at work.

The concept of aucitya (propriety, appropriateness), theorised by Kṣemendra in his Aucityavicāracarcā (11th century CE), holds that the highest mark of poetic success is the perfect fit between form and feeling. By this criterion, Mandal's choice of the haiku/tanka form for certain poems — compressed, syllabically disciplined, image-driven — is an act of aucitya: the fragmented, miniaturist form enacts the fragmentation of the world it describes. Similarly, the ghazal form (two ghazals appear at the end of Nistuki) carries its own tradition of the beloved's absence and the lover's wandering — a tradition that, in Mandal's hands, becomes a meditation on the absence of the homeland and the wandering of the exile.

[4] T.K. Oommen, 'Linguistic Diversity,' in Sociology (1988), p. 291–293, citing Grierson and S.K. Chatterjee, as quoted in Gajendra Thakur, Parallel History Part 1, Videha.

## II.5 New Critical Close Reading: Selected Poems

Applying the New Critical method of close reading — bracketing biographical and historical context temporarily in order to attend to the poem as a verbal

structure — one observes in the laghu kavita (short poems) section a rigorous economy of language. The poem 'Hansi Lahas' (Laughing Corpse) juxtaposes humour and death in a manner that recalls the 'metaphysical conceit' of Donne or the black irony of Brecht. The poem 'Agilaah' (Doorstep/Threshold) creates an image of fire and water as the fundamental contradictions of the social world — the 'manah ka mainah' (the currency of the mind) a phrase that enacts what Cleanth Brooks called the 'paradox' at the heart of significant poetry.

The poem 'Akash' ('Sky' / 'Alas') — a two-word laghu kavita — functions as a compressed haiku-like utterance that exemplifies Ānandavardhana's dhvani at its most concentrated. The sky is both the physical sky of the Mithila landscape and the expression of longing, regret, or aspiration. Such compression resists paraphrase: the poem means more than it says, in the precise sense that dhvani theory describes.

The tanka sequence reveals Mandal's engagement with formal experiment. The tanka form (5-7-5-7-7 syllable pattern) is adapted into Maithili's syllabic and tonal system, creating a productive tension between the imported form and the native phonological material. This is what Homi Bhabha would call a moment of 'hybridity' — where two cultural systems interact and produce something irreducible to either source.

## II.6 Environmental Poetics and the Kosi-Kamla Landscape

A dimension of Nistuki that demands explicit critical attention is its environmental consciousness. The Mithila region, situated between the Himalayas and the Gangetic plain, is one of the most flood-prone areas of the world. The rivers Kosi and Kamla are both sustaining and destructive forces, culturally sacred and economically devastating. Mandal's poetry registers this ambivalence. Water appears throughout the collection not as a simple symbol of fertility or purification, but as a complex force — the same water that makes the soil of Mithila famously productive also displaces millions, drowns crops, and erodes the very ground on which communities stand.

In the framework of Lawrence Buell's ecocriticism, Mandal's poetry performs what Buell calls 'environmental representation' — a mode of writing that takes the non-human world seriously as a presence and a force, not merely as backdrop or symbol for human drama. The poems about the gam, the fields, the gachhi (orchards), and the seasonal rhythms of agricultural life constitute an

ecological archive — preserving, in lyric form, a knowledge of place that is being lost to outmigration, monoculture, and environmental degradation.

## III. Jagdish Prasad Mandalak Kavya Sansar (2022): Critical Praxis and Research Method

### III.1 Overview of the Work

Jagdish Prasad Mandalak Kavya Sansar (The Poetic Universe of Jagdish Prasad Mandal) is a full-length research monograph published by Pallavi Prakashan, Nirmali (Supaul, Bihar) in 2022 (ISBN 978-93-93135-10-0, Rs. 300). Authored by Dr. Umesh Mandal, the work is subtitled 'Research Analysis' (Anusandhan Vishleshan) and constitutes a systematic critical study of the poetry of Jagdish Prasad Mandal — himself one of the most significant figures of the Parallel Maithili tradition, awarded the Sahitya Akademi Award in 2021 for his novel Pangu.

The monograph proceeds through the full arc of Jagdish Prasad Mandal's poetic career, examining individual collections in sequence: Indradhanushi Akas, Raat-Din, Teen Jeth Egarhm Magh, Sarita, Gitanjali, Suwael Pokharik Jaaith, Satbed, Chunauti, Rahasa Chauri, Kamdhenu, Man Mathan, Akas Ganga — followed by a comprehensive chronological index of his verse works. The critical apparatus demonstrates Umesh Mandal's dual competence: as a reader formed within the classical Maithili tradition (with its Sanskrit-inflected aesthetic vocabulary) and as a literary critic alert to the social dimensions of literary production.

### III.2 Biographical Recovery and the Ethics of Critical Care

The opening chapter of Jagdish Prasad Mandalak Kavya Sansar performs a task that is at once scholarly and political: it recovers the biography of Jagdish Prasad Mandal not as a series of dates and publications, but as a social history of a writer from a marginalised community in post-independence Bihar. Born on 5 July 1947 in Berma village, Jhanjharpur sub-district, Madhubani — the same landscape as Umesh Mandal's own formative world — Jagdish Prasad Mandal lost his father at age three and grew up in conditions of material

scarcity that paradoxically produced unusual intellectual richness through the strength of the extended family and the community environment.

Drawing extensively from Gajendra Thakur's biography (Jagdish Prasad Mandal: Ekta Biography, 2013), Umesh Mandal traces the trajectory from village childhood through an M.A. in Hindi and Political Science, to decades of social activism — 35 years of court cases and jail time on behalf of lower-caste communities in Mithila — before arriving at literary recognition. The Videha Parallel History Framework's account of this trajectory is sharper: it notes that the Sahitya Akademi systematically ignored Jagdish Prasad Mandal for decades, that the RTI investigation confirmed zero assignments to him despite his stature, and that the award that finally came (2021) was a belated acknowledgement of work that had long been central to any honest account of contemporary Maithili literature.

Umesh Mandal's critical method here is ethically self-conscious: by framing the literary study within the social biography, he follows the precedent of Indian critical traditions (particularly the Marxist-influenced criticism of Ramvilas Sharma and the dalit-bahujan critical practice emerging from Ambedkarite intellectual culture) that refuse to separate the text from the conditions of its production. This is not a reductive sociologism; Mandal goes on to read the poetry with close attention to language and form. But the biographical frame insists that no reading of this work can be innocent of the social world it emerges from and responds to.

## III.3 The Navya Nyāya Method Applied to Critical Analysis

The intellectual tradition of Navya Nyāya — the 'New Logic' school of Indian epistemology founded by Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya in his Tattvacintāmaṇi (14th century, Mithila) — provides a remarkably apt methodological lens for evaluating Umesh Mandal's critical practice.

Gaṅgeśa's epistemology centres on the question of pramā — valid knowledge — and the conditions under which it can be established. For Gaṅgeśa, knowledge is not simply a mental state but a relational event: a jñāna (knowledge-event) involves a knowing subject (pramātā), an object (prameya), a means of knowing (pramāṇa), and a result (pramāphala). The four canonical pramāṇas are perception (pratyakṣa), inference (anumāna), comparison (upamāna), and testimony (śabda).

Applying this framework to Umesh Mandal's critical work in Jagdish Prasad Mandalak Kavya Sansar, one can identify four corresponding epistemic operations:

1. Pratyakṣa (direct perception): Mandal's close reading of Jagdish Prasad Mandal's poems — attending to specific images, word choices, rhythmic structures, and thematic patterns — is the critical analogue of perceptual knowledge. He reads the text as it presents itself, without prior theoretical impositions.

2. Anumāna (inference): Mandal infers the social world from the textual evidence — reading the poems' images of caste oppression, agricultural hardship, and communal solidarity as indices of the social conditions that produced them. This inferential move follows the Navya Nyāya logic of vyāpti (universal concomitance) — if literary images of this kind, then a social world of this kind.

3. Upamāna (comparison): The study places Jagdish Prasad Mandal's poetry in comparative relation with other Maithili poets and literary traditions, establishing its distinctiveness through a logic of resemblance and difference that is the literary-critical equivalent of upamāna.

4. Śabda (testimony): Mandal draws on the testimony of earlier critics, biographers, and the statements of Jagdish Prasad Mandal himself — using these as valid sources of knowledge about the work while remaining alert to their situatedness and possible biases.

The Navya Nyāya tradition's concern with ābhāsa (error, epistemic failure) and its conditions is equally relevant: Umesh Mandal's critique of the Sahitya Akademi's canonical selections implicitly invokes the concept of viparīta-jñāna (inverted or false knowledge) — the knowledge-claims of the mainstream critical establishment are shown to be epistemically defective, produced by the wrong pramāṇas (testimonial chains corrupted by caste interest) and issuing in false prameyas (misconstructions of literary value).

## III.4 Contribution to Maithili Literary Historiography

Jagdish Prasad Mandalak Kavya Sansar makes several contributions to Maithili literary historiography that deserve recognition. First, it produces a systematic and chronologically comprehensive account of a major poet's oeuvre — a form of scholarly labour that is fundamental to any literary culture's self-knowledge and that has been systematically denied to Parallel Maithili writers by the

official critical establishment. Second, it models a mode of critical engagement that honours both the artisanal dimensions of the poetry (its language, form, imagery) and its social embeddedness — a both/and rather than either/or approach to the art-society relationship. Third, by placing the work in the context of the poet's biography and social activism, it performs the ethical function of criticism: making visible the conditions under which literature is produced and suppressed.

In terms of the Videha Parallel History Framework, the monograph is itself a node in the counter-archival project: by publishing with Pallavi Prakashan (a small press based in Nirmali, Supaul — not a metropolitan or academically prestigious house), Umesh Mandal demonstrates the institutional logic of parallel literary culture: self-reliant, locally embedded, not dependent on the approval of the gatekeeping institutions that have historically marginalised these voices.

## IV. Umesh Mandal and the Videha Parallel History Framework

### IV.1 The Framework's Central Claims

The Videha Parallel History of Mithila and Maithili Literature, authored by Gajendra Thakur and serialised across multiple parts on www.videha.co.in, argues for a fundamental reorientation of Maithili literary historiography. Its central claims, as elaborated across Parts 1 through 10 of the serialised text, may be summarised as follows:

The mainstream Maithili canon as institutionalised by the Sahitya Akademi since 1965 has systematically privileged upper-caste (predominantly Maithil Brahmin) writers while suppressing democratic, folk, Dalit, feminist, and Nepal-side traditions. This is not accidental oversight but structural exclusion, documented by RTI data. The Buddhist Charyapadas (8th–12th centuries) are foundational texts of Maithili lyric that the mainstream canon treats as peripheral or pre-Maithili. The philosopher Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya — whose Tattvacintāmaṇi is the founding text of Navya Nyāya and who was himself a son of Mithila — has had his intercaste origins suppressed by the very brahminical establishment that claims his heritage. The 'true avant-garde' of contemporary Maithili are Jagdish Prasad Mandal (novelist), Rajdeo Mandal

(poet), and Bechan Thakur (dramatist) — all long ignored by official machinery. The digital counter-archive constituted by Videha — thousands of books digitised, 11,000 palm-leaf Tirhuta manuscripts transcribed, Braille and Tirhuta Unicode contributions — is itself a form of parallel institutional practice.

## IV.2 Umesh Mandal's Position Within the Framework

Umesh Mandal occupies a position of unusual range within this framework. As co-editor of Videha, he was an institutional actor within the parallel movement — one of the architects of its digital infrastructure. As a poet (Nistuki) and scholar (Jagdish Prasad Mandalak Kavya Sansar), he is a creative and critical contributor to the parallel tradition. And as the primary developer of Maithili Wikipedia content, he performs the archival function of expanding the language's public knowledge base beyond the confines of any single literary movement.

His village of origin — Berma, Madhubani — is significant within the Parallel History Framework's symbolic geography: it is the same village that gave the world Jagdish Prasad Mandal, suggesting a local intellectual community of unusual vitality, one that has produced multiple significant writers despite (or because of) its distance from metropolitan literary centres. The Parallel History Framework's concept of 'literature from below' — grounded in agrarian experience, caste consciousness, and ecological reality — is embodied in Mandal's entire literary career.

## IV.3 The Gaṅgeśa Connection: Navya Nyāya, Mithila, and Literary Epistemology

One of the most intellectually generative aspects of the Videha Parallel History Framework is its recovery of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's intercaste origins — a suppressed fact that the framework argues transforms our understanding of both the philosopher and the social world that produced him. Gaṅgeśa is said, on the evidence of original Dooshan Panji records, to have married a woman from the leather-tanning community and to have been born five years after his father's death — facts that disrupt the brahminical narrative of his legacy.

This recovery has implications beyond the biographical. If Navya Nyāya — the most rigorous epistemological system produced in pre-modern India —

emerged from a social situation of intercaste border-crossing and community mixing, then its methodology of radical questioning (ābhāsa-analysis, anvaya-vyatireka method, the critique of inherited testimony) carries a democratic and anti-hierarchical charge that the brahminical appropriation of the tradition has suppressed. Reading Umesh Mandal's critical practice through this lens — as a form of Navya Nyāya at work in literary culture — is not a metaphor but a substantive claim: the method of epistemological rigour that demands that every knowledge-claim be tested against its pramāṇa (means of valid knowledge) is precisely what the Parallel History Framework performs in its critique of the Sahitya Akademi's canonical selections.

## V. Intersecting Western Critical Frameworks

### V.1 Postcolonial Theory

Edward Said's concept of 'contrapuntal reading' — attending to the voices that a dominant text suppresses or marginalises — is immediately applicable to Mandal's position in Maithili literary culture. Just as Said proposed reading the British novel against the grain of its imperial assumptions, the Parallel History Framework proposes reading Maithili literary history against the grain of its caste-brahminical assumptions. Mandal's poetry and criticism perform this contrapuntal function: they speak from within the tradition while refusing its exclusions.

Homi Bhabha's concept of 'the third space' — the space of cultural hybridity where new identities are negotiated between dominant and subaltern positions — is illuminating for reading Nistuki's formal experiments. The haiku/tanka adaptations, the ghazal form applied to Maithili content, the intersection of classical Sanskrit rasa vocabulary with a vernacular language of rural Bihar: these are not failures of cultural authenticity but productions of new cultural space, the 'third space' where Maithili modernity is being invented.

### V.2 Subaltern Studies and Voice

Ranajit Guha's concept of 'the prose of counter-insurgency' — the way dominant discourse systematically misrepresents subaltern agency — can be applied to the Sahitya Akademi's canonical account of Maithili literature. That

account, by omitting Mandal, Jagdish Prasad Mandal, Rajdeo Mandal, and Bechan Thakur, produces what might be called a 'prose of counter-literary insurgency': a version of the tradition that erases its most politically challenging elements. Umesh Mandal's critical and poetic work performs the counter-task of Spivak's subaltern historiography: making the suppressed voice legible, not by speaking 'for' it in a way that reproduces the structure of silencing, but by creating the conditions (archival, digital, critical) under which it can speak for itself.

## V.3 New Historicism and Cultural Materialism

Stephen Greenblatt's New Historicism, with its insistence on the mutual implication of literary texts and the social energies of their historical moment, provides a useful framework for understanding Mandal's dual project. The poems of Nistuki are not self-contained aesthetic objects floating above the social world; they are 'thick' cultural documents, resonating with the specific social energies of early twenty-first century Mithila — the migration crisis, the environmental crisis, the crisis of linguistic and cultural identity under conditions of Hindi-belt standardisation. Equally, Jagdish Prasad Mandalak Kavya Sansar is not merely a critical monograph; it is a cultural-material intervention in the ongoing struggle over who counts as a significant writer and whose literary labour is recognised as such.

## V.4 Reader-Response Theory

Wolfgang Iser's concept of the 'implied reader' and the 'gaps' in a literary text that the reader is invited to fill is relevant to Mandal's poetry in a specific way. Nistuki's implied reader is a Maithili speaker who shares the cultural reference points — the festivals (Chhath, Bhogi), the river-names, the village practices — that the poems invoke. For this reader, the poems are full of what Iser calls 'determinate gaps': the poem 'says' the threshold, and the reader 'fills in' the entire experiential world that the threshold invokes. For a non-Maithili reader (whether Indian or international), these gaps become sites of cross-cultural learning and also, inevitably, of partial comprehension — a reminder of the untranslatability that is part of every literature's specificity.

# VI. Synthesis and Critical Assessment

## VI.1 Strengths and Achievements

Assessed across the full range of criteria deployed above — Indian aesthetic, Western critical, epistemological, and institutional — Dr. Umesh Mandal's work presents a pattern of coherent achievement. As a poet, his primary strength lies in formal economy, ecological consciousness, and the lyric registration of social dislocation. As a scholar, his primary strength lies in the ethical seriousness of his critical care — the refusal to separate the literary from the social, the text from its conditions of production. As a digital archivist, his contribution to Maithili's linguistic survival in the digital era is among the most significant of his generation.

Within the Parallel History Framework's terms, Mandal exemplifies the figure of the 'organic intellectual' — Gramsci's term for the thinker who emerges from and remains connected to a subaltern class, whose intellectual work is inseparable from the political project of that class's self-emancipation. He does not merely write about the Mithila peasant community; he works on behalf of that community's cultural survival and recognition, through every register of his activity.

## VI.2 Areas for Further Development

A critical appreciation must also note the areas where Mandal's work invites further development. The poetry of Nistuki, for all its strengths, is occasionally uneven in its formal discipline — some of the longer poems would benefit from tighter structural organisation. The critical monograph on Jagdish Prasad Mandal, while comprehensive, tends toward a descriptive-summary mode in some sections, and would be strengthened by more sustained engagement with close-reading analysis of specific poems and their formal devices. A future comparative study that places both Jagdish Prasad Mandal and Umesh Mandal's own poetry in relation to other South Asian literatures of migration, ecology, and caste — Bengali, Bhojpuri, Odia — would extend the reach of both critical and creative projects.

### VI.3 The Question of Reception and Recognition

The most striking fact about Umesh Mandal's literary career — and the fact that the Videha Parallel History Framework insists upon most forcefully — is the gap between the significance of the work and the recognition it has received from official literary institutions. Despite his extraordinary contributions to Maithili language, literature, and digital infrastructure — contributions that are documented, quantifiable, and of lasting cultural value — Mandal has received no Sahitya Akademi recognition, no translation grants, no official institutional acknowledgement of the kind routinely given to writers of lesser achievement from the dominant caste communities of the Maithili advisory board.

From the Navya Nyāya perspective, this gap between prameya (true object of knowledge) and pramā (valid knowledge-claim) in the institutional domain is a case of collective epistemic failure — viparīta-jñāna produced by corrupted testimony (anāpta-śabda) and motivated inference (sa-doṣa anumāna). The correction of this failure requires not merely individual recognition but institutional reform: a reconfiguration of the conditions under which literary value is assessed and awarded in the Maithili context.

## VII. Conclusion: The Voice That Names the Voiceless

Nistuki — 'the voiceless one,' or perhaps 'one without answer' — is a title that resonates beyond the individual book. It names a condition: the condition of the writer whose language has been denied recognition, whose community has been excluded from the literary canon, whose work has been performed in the face of institutional indifference. That Umesh Mandal chose this title for his poetry collection is itself an act of literary self-consciousness: he knows the position he occupies, and he names it.

But the title also carries an implicit challenge. The voiceless one who writes is, by the act of writing, no longer voiceless. The one without answer who composes poems and critical monographs and Wikipedia entries and digital archives is, by all those acts, generating answers — not merely for himself, but for the community whose cultural memory he is preserving and whose literary achievement he is documenting. In this sense, Nistuki is both a lament and a refusal: a lament for the conditions of silencing, and a refusal of those conditions through the sheer abundance of cultural production.

Viewed through the convergent lenses of Indian rasa theory (karuṇa as the ground of ethical solidarity), Navya Nyāya epistemology (pramā as the commitment to valid knowledge against motivated error), the Videha Parallel History Framework (counter-archive as political praxis), and Western critical theory (contrapuntal reading, subaltern voice, environmental poetics) — Umesh Mandal emerges as one of the most significant figures in contemporary Maithili literary culture. The full critical accounting of his work — and the institutional recognition that work merits — is a project that this appreciation initiates, but that the literary community of Mithila, and those who care about the world's linguistic diversity, must continue.

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'A Journey Through Maithili Literature with Kathakar Ashok.' Outlook India. February 2024.

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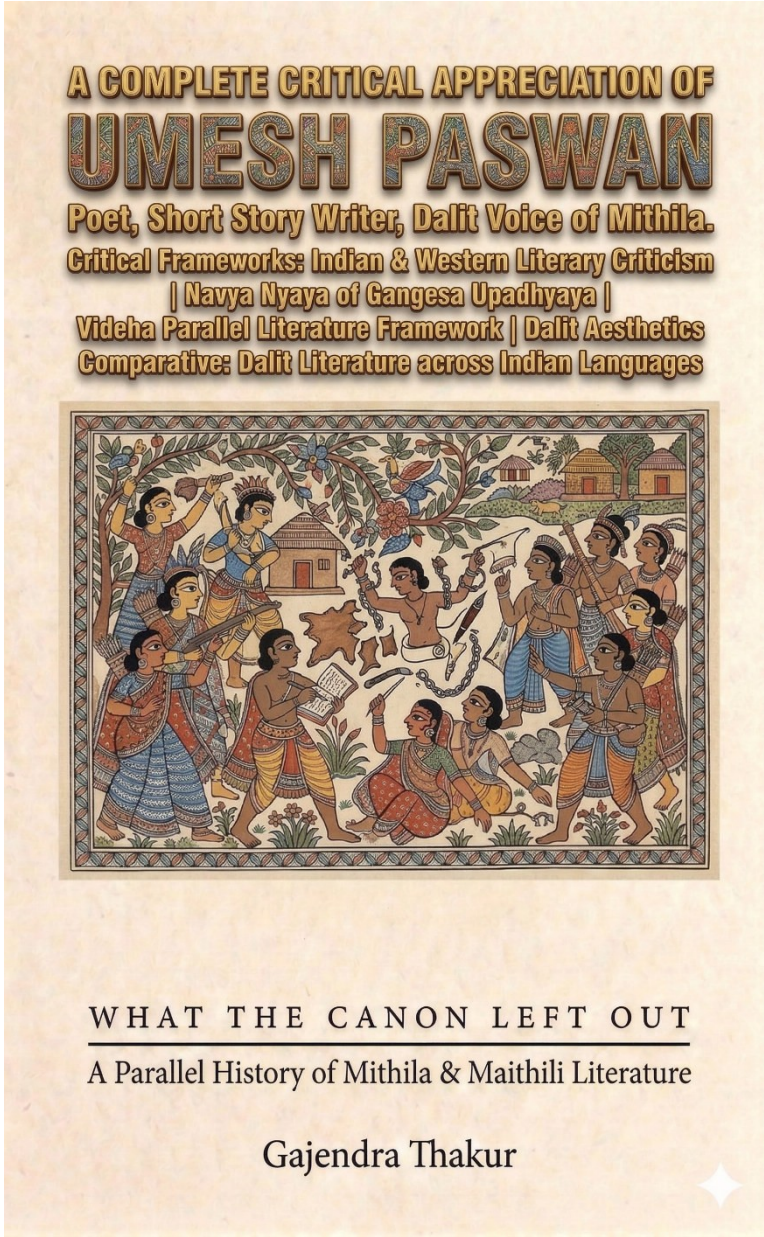
*All translations from Maithili are approximate renderings for critical purposes only.*

**LESSON 091 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**



# A COMPLETE CRITICAL APPRECIATION OF

# UMESH PASWAN

*Poet, Short Story Writer, Dalit Voice of Mithila*

Critical Frameworks:

Indian & Western Literary Criticism | Navya Nyaya of Gangesa Upadhyaya

Videha Parallel Literature Framework | Dalit Aesthetics | Bharata's Natyashastra

Comparative: Dalit Literature across Indian Languages

## Preface

Umesh Paswan is a poet and short story writer from the Paswan (Dusadh) Dalit community of Mithila, Bihar — a voice that the Videha Parallel Literature Movement has identified as one of its most significant contributors to the Maithili literary tradition. He is explicitly named by the India Seminar's survey of Maithili digital culture (Mithilesh Kumar Jha, 2021) among 'the most notable' writers given a platform by Videha alongside Jagadish Prasad Mandal, Rajdeo Mandal, Munnaji, Ashish Anchinhar, and Chandan Kumar Jha. The Outlook India survey of Maithili literature (2024) similarly identifies Umesh Paswan as among those writers who 'present the Dalit point of view' in contemporary Maithili writing, alongside Mahendra Narayan Ram, Taranand Viyogi, Ramkrishna Pararthi, Raghunath Mukhiya, and Pritam Nishad.

The present critical appreciation examines two archival works: Virnit Ras (lit. 'Extracted/Distilled Rasa', a poetry collection published by Shruti Prakashan, Delhi, 2012; ISBN 978-93-80538-71-6; 127 pages), and Mujrim (lit. 'The Accused/Guilty', a collection of sixteen short stories published by Pallavi Prakashan, Nirmali/Berma, 2026; ISBN 978-93-48865-94-6; 105 pages, first edition). Together, these two works span fourteen years of Paswan's

literary production and represent the full range of his creative engagement — the lyric-political voice of the poetry collection and the social-realist narrative voice of the stories — making him a writer of exceptional range and commitment within the Maithili Dalit literary tradition.

The critical framework employed is pluralist and deliberately interdisciplinary: Gajendra Thakur's Videha Parallel Literature Framework (which situates Paswan's work within the counter-hegemonic literary project of the Videha movement); Gangesa Upadhyaya's Navya Nyaya epistemology (with its analysis of pramana, bhrama, and prama); Bharata's Natyashastra (particularly the rasa theory and its application to social drama); Indian aesthetic theories of Dhvani (Anandavardhana) and Vakrokti (Kuntaka); and Western critical theories including Dalit aesthetics (Limbale), postcolonial theory (Spivak), social realism (Lukács), Brecht's Epic Theatre, feminist intersectionality (Crenshaw), and the tradition of global protest poetry (Langston Hughes, Pablo Neruda, Namdeo Dhasal).

# Chapter I: Umesh Paswan — Community, Context, and the Videha Framework

## 1.1 The Paswan/Dusadh Community in Mithila

The Paswan community (also known as Dusadh) is one of the scheduled castes of Bihar, classified as Harijan/Dalit in the constitutional framework. In the traditional caste hierarchy of Mithila, the Dusadh community was assigned the occupational role of village watchman (chaukidar) and associated low-status service functions. They are historically concentrated in North Bihar and have maintained a distinct cultural identity — including their own folk traditions, dances (the Jat-Jatin tradition), and oral literary heritage — while being subjected to the full apparatus of caste discrimination: untouchability, exclusion from religious spaces, denial of educational opportunities, and economic exploitation through caste-based labour obligations.

The Paswan community in the post-independence period has produced significant political leadership (Ram Vilas Paswan, founder of the Lok Jan Shakti Party, emerged from this community) and has benefited from constitutional reservations in education and employment. However, as Umesh Paswan's own poetry and fiction document with great specificity, the structural conditions of caste discrimination — the daily micro-aggressions, the

institutional bias, the economic marginalisation — persist in rural Mithila alongside formal constitutional equality. His work is the literary record of this gap: between constitutional promise and lived reality, between formal equality and actual dignity.

## 1.2 The Videha Movement and Umesh Paswan's Place Within It

The Videha eJournal (www.videha.co.in, ISSN 2229-547X, since 2008, edited by Gajendra Thakur) has been the primary institutional home of Umesh Paswan's literary career. The movement's manifesto — 'Manushimih Samskritam' (Humans First in Culture) — and its project of recovering 'the missing portions, the ignored and non-represented aspects of society' in mainstream Maithili literary production defines the institutional context within which his work gains its significance.

Paswan's acknowledgement of this context is explicit. The dedicatory poem of Virnit Ras — its Aamukh (preface) — declares: 'Sahitya-purush Jagdish Prasad Mandal, Gajendra Thakur jik / asirwad chhi Virnit Ras. / Sahitya sewame jutala vyakti / Umesh Mandal ka preranaka / parinam chhi Virnit Ras' (The blessings of literary personalities Jagdish Prasad Mandal and Gajendra Thakur, / and the result of the inspiration of / Umesh Mandal engaged in literary service — / this is Virnit Ras). This threefold acknowledgement — of Jagdish Prasad Mandal (the major Yadav-community novelist), Gajendra Thakur (the Videha editor), and Umesh Mandal (the digital Maithili pioneer) — situates Paswan squarely within the Videha parallel literary tradition and declares his conscious participation in its project.

The title itself — Virnit Ras — carries philosophical weight. 'Virnit' (from Sanskrit 'vi-nit', meaning extracted, distilled, or purified) combined with 'Ras' (the classical term for aesthetic essence, flavour, or the emotional experience of art) suggests a poetic project of refinement: extracting the essential emotional truth from the raw material of Dalit social experience and transforming it into literary aesthetic form. This is simultaneously a claim to aesthetic seriousness (the poetry aspires to the classical category of rasa) and a political claim (the Dalit community's experience has rasa — aesthetic essence — worthy of literary distillation).

## 1.3 Gangesa Upadhyaya and the Mithila Epistemological Context

The Navya Nyaya system of Gangesa Upadhyaya — the fourteenth-century Mithila philosopher whose Tattvacintamani established the rigorous analysis of the four pramanas (pratyaksha, anumana, upamana, shabda) —

provides the philosophical background against which Umesh Paswan's literature must be understood. As the Videha critical literature has established, Gangesa's own family background was socially marginalised — his family was 'completely ignored' in the Brahminical Panji genealogical system — making him a Mithila intellectual who achieved greatness from outside the social establishment's recognition.

Applied to Umesh Paswan's work: his poetry and fiction constitute a pratyaksha-pramana (direct perceptual evidence) of the Paswan community's life in contemporary Mithila — a form of knowledge that the mainstream Maithili literary tradition had systematically excluded. They correct the bhrama (false cognition) that 'Maithili literature' exhausts itself in Brahmin-Kayastha literary production, establishing the prama (valid cognition) that Dalit social experience — in all its specific, embodied, community-embedded richness — constitutes legitimate and essential literary knowledge.

# Chapter II: Virnit Ras — The Poetry Collection

## 2.1 Overview and Structure

Virnit Ras (Shruti Prakashan, Delhi, 2012; ISBN 978-93-80538-71-6) contains approximately sixty-five poems, spanning a remarkable range of themes and registers. The collection's table of contents reveals its thematic breadth: from poems directly addressing political corruption ('Neta', 'Netaji Namaskar', 'Fussi-Fatka'), social injustice ('Samaj', 'Kakul-Chhap', 'Dalidar'), caste discrimination ('Harijaan', 'Garala Murd'), ecological concerns ('Kosi', 'Barkhak Mausam', 'Baadh'), migration ('Gelhe Ghar Chhi', 'Palthan Lal'), gender dynamics ('Mithilaak Naari', 'Mainaak', 'Nattin'), patriotism and national unity ('Paavana Bhoomi', 'Hum Yuva', 'Jeetak Jhanda'), devotional and seasonal themes ('Purnima', 'Phaguname', 'Vasant'), to personal and philosophical meditations ('Manak Biswas', 'Rasta', 'Athaah').

This breadth is not diffusion but integration: all the themes connect through the unifying perspective of the Dalit Maithili subject who simultaneously loves Mithila's natural beauty, suffers under its social structures, aspires to constitutional rights, mourns labour migration's cultural cost, and insists on the dignity of the community's life and work. The collection's preface poem — beginning 'Pehile arthak prayaas chhi Virnit Ras / Desame badhala bhrashtacharaka / Vedik ilaaj chhi Virnit Ras' (This is the first

effort of meaning, Virnit Ras / It is the Vedic cure / for the corruption that has grown in the country) — frames the entire collection as a social and moral intervention: poetry as medicine, as corrective instrument, as 'janaadhikaar lel / buland awaaz' (a loud voice for people's rights).

## 2.2 Key Poems and Their Analysis

### *2.2.1 Kagaz (Paper)*

The opening poem 'Kagaz' (Paper) is the collection's most subtle and formally complex piece. The poem presents the blank page as its speaking subject: 'Saada kaagaj chhi ham / saadagi samael achhi hamrame' (I am a blank white paper / simplicity is contained within me). The paper is governed by the multi-coloured pen ('satrangi rangak kalama') that has 'purn adhikar jamaune achhi hamra upar' (established full authority over me). The paper is surrounded, enclosed ('Gheral rahi chhi ham / kalama ka maikhas / aabadh bha dewalsam'), yet maintains its essential nature through 'tyaag-balidan da ka ham apan / ek deshbhakta san samaj kar / sewame lagal rahi chhi ham' (sacrifice and dedication I gave for / serving society as a patriot).

This poem operates simultaneously as a meditation on the writer's relationship to language and as an allegory of the Dalit subject's relationship to social power. The 'blank paper' — simultaneously innocent, pure, and powerless — figures the Dalit who is defined and controlled by others' authority ('the pen of multi-coloured authority'). Yet the paper's fundamental nature — its 'saadagi' (simplicity, purity) — cannot be entirely dominated: it remains itself even under the inscription of others. Applied through Kuntaka's Vakrokti theory: the poem achieves its effect through an 'oblique expression' that refuses to name the social condition it describes, instead encoding the dynamics of Dalit experience in the metaphor of paper and pen — a vakrata that carries more emotional force than direct statement would achieve.

### *2.2.2 Samaj (Society)*

'Samaj' is the collection's most programmatic Ambedkarite poem, though Ambedkar is not named. It declares: 'Khushaamadi aa ne begaari karab ham / apan karmar baatpar sadikhan chalab ham' (We will do neither flattery nor bonded labour / We will always walk on the path of our own karma). The poem identifies the specific social pathologies it resists: 'Daab-chaap, dahej-ashiksha, andhavishaasak / jaalka torab ham' (The web of pressure, dowry, illiteracy, superstition / we will break). The key political declaration comes in

the final lines: 'Mrityu saiyan je dhaene achhi / Dalit ka adhikar / okara / samanataa hetu larab ham' (We will fight for equality / against those who have held / the rights of Dalits / as if on a deathbed). This is the classic Ambedkarite declaration of rights — not supplication but assertion, not appeal but demand.

### *2.2.3 Ravan-Kans (Ravan-Kansa)*

This poem offers a striking mythological reinterpretation that marks Paswan as a sophisticated Dalit literary thinker. The poem opens with a figure who 'Murcchit bha khasal bhoomi par / Gumaanka dherapar / ja kai baital chhal oo' (fell unconscious on the ground / and sat on the heap of pride) and who walked on the path of 'adharma' (unrighteousness). The poem's climactic identification: 'Ki Ravan-Kans akhan dhari / nai maaral gael jena / Hu-ba-hu karmas / ekke shatabdime gadhal san lagait chhal oo' (It seemed as if Ravan and Kansa / had not yet been slain / their deeds were identical / moulded in the same century). The poem then makes the identification explicit — this is the figure who 'Khun sa rangi kai apan hath / Americaka World Trade Center se / shuruaat kenel chhal oo' (coloured his hands with blood / from America's World Trade Centre / had made a beginning).

This identification of global terrorism with the mythological demons Ravan and Kansa is a remarkable move: it relocates the Maithili mythological tradition's stock villains into the twenty-first century's global political landscape, while simultaneously doing what Dalit poets have consistently done — redeploying Hindu mythology's narrative of oppressor and liberator in the service of a politics of dignity and resistance. The poem enacts what Dalit scholars call 'mythological counter-reading': using the dominant culture's own sacred stories to critique the dominant culture's exercise of power.

### *2.2.4 Gelhe Ghar Chhi (The Home That Has Gone)*

This poem addresses one of the most urgent social realities of Mithila's poor communities: the seasonal male migration to Punjab for agricultural labour. The poem's central image is a terse, devastating observation: 'Ja akhar mahinae budh barad / pajrame darad / Punjab me marad achhi / ta samujhu he gelhe ghar chhi' (If in the Asharh month the old bullocks / feel pain in their ribs / the men are in Punjab / then understand, the home has gone). The collocation of the old bullocks' pain and the absent men is a precise agricultural image: in Asharh (June-July), the ploughing and planting season reaches its peak, and the bullocks' pain signals that there is no one to rest them, no male hands to lighten their load, because the men are in distant Punjab. The poem uses the

agricultural calendar — the specific month, the specific animal's specific physical condition — as the marker of social absence and its consequences.

From Anandavardhana's Dhvani perspective, this poem's power lies in its vyanjana-artha (suggested meaning): the bullocks' pain 'suggests' the broken household, the migrant's longing, the woman left behind with double labour, the children without fathers. The literal image carries this weight of unstated suffering through the resonance that Dhvani theory identifies as the supreme dimension of poetic meaning.

### *2.2.5 Dalidar (Poverty)*

'Dalidar' is the poem in which Paswan most directly addresses the relationship between caste and poverty. The poem issues a challenge: 'Saahityak dalidara keteo juluma karaie hamaraapar / kiyoa ta baaju / kiyoa hamara disas awaaz uthaau' (The poverty of literature does such injustice to us / Please speak someone / Raise your voice for us from somewhere). This is a meta-literary poem — a poem about the injustice of literary exclusion — that names the specific condition: the mainstream Maithili literary tradition's neglect of Dalit experience as a form of literary poverty ('saahityak dalidar').

The poem then pivots from complaint to aspiration: 'Apan somniya bala raasa aab nai sunab ham' (We will no longer listen to the flowing rasa of our own dream) — a refusal of the consoling dream-rasa, the passive aesthetic experience that substitutes imaginative pleasure for actual resistance. This refusal of passive rasa in favour of active political assertion is one of the defining moves of Dalit aesthetics — the insistence that beauty and feeling must serve justice.

### *2.2.6 Mithilaak Naari (The Woman of Mithila)*

This poem addresses gender within the specific cultural context of Mithila, engaging with the complex social position of Mithila's women — celebrated in classical literature and folk song, yet subjected to the same patriarchal constraints that operate across South Asian cultures. 'Omhara biaa je ukharai chhai mahila jan / koi karai chhai saassu-nandik nina-bina / koi gabaai chhai sohar-samadain' (Meanwhile the woman unroots the weeds / some listen to the nagging of mother-in-law and sister-in-law / some sing sohar and samadain songs). The poem documents the multiple layers of a Maithili woman's life — agricultural labour, domestic oppression, and the cultural tradition of women's songs (sohar at birth, samadain at marriage) — without

romanticising any layer. The woman is simultaneously worker, victim, and cultural carrier.

### *2.2.7 Hariian (Harijan)*

This poem addresses the identity category of 'Harijan' — Gandhi's term for Dalit communities that has been rejected by many Dalit activists as patronising — with specific political consciousness: 'Ham dalit chhi / mehnati-majduuri kae kai bitabai chhi apan jeevan / taiyo jarait achhi' (We are Dalit / working hard in labour we spend our lives / yet it burns). This declaration — 'Ham dalit chhi' (We are Dalit) — asserts the political identity of Dalit as a self-chosen category of resistance rather than a social-reform paternalism's gift ('Harijan'). The burning metaphor ('taiyo jarait achhi') echoes Rajdeo Mandal's poetry and connects to the blood-and-fire imagery of Dalit poetry across languages.

## 2.3 The Preface Poem as Critical Statement

The Aamukh (preface) poem of Virnit Ras — structured as a litany of declarations about what the collection is — serves as a remarkable critical self-statement. Each line identifies a different function of the poetry: 'Janaklyaanaka lel / pahila athak prayaas chhi Virnit Ras' (For the welfare of the people / a first tireless effort is Virnit Ras); 'Janaadhikaarak lel / buland awaaz chhi Virnit Ras' (For people's rights / a loud voice is Virnit Ras); 'Dalit upejhit vargak / pahichan chhi Virnit Ras' (For the Dalit neglected class / an identity is Virnit Ras); 'Oonch-nichaka bhed-bhaav / rakhanihaarak upar / shabdak prahaar chhi Virnit Ras' (Against those who maintain high-low discrimination / a word-strike is Virnit Ras).

This litany of functions — welfare, rights, identity, word-strike — maps onto the classical Natyashastra's account of the purposes of performance art: Bharata identifies the functions of natya as including providing 'counsel to those in distress, rest to the weary, amusement for those seeking diversion, and knowledge for those desiring it.' Paswan's poetry claims all of these functions simultaneously, while adding specifically Dalit political functions (identity formation, rights assertion, confrontation with discrimination) that the classical framework did not need to articulate because caste was not its problem.

# Chapter III: Mujrim — The Short Story Collection

## 3.1 The Title and Its Significance

The title Mujrim (The Accused/Guilty/Wrongdoer) is the collection's most brilliant critical gesture. The English blurb on the collection's copyright page articulates this explicitly: 'Here, mujrim becomes not merely a wrongdoer, but a label imposed by systems of power and privilege.' The word mujrim — from Urdu/Persian, meaning criminal, accused, wrongdoer — carries the weight of legal and moral condemnation in the Hindustani cultural sphere. By choosing this word as his collection's title, Paswan performs a semiotic inversion: he places the label 'criminal' not on the Dalit characters who are routinely criminalised by caste society, but on the social system that imposes that label.

This is precisely the move that Dalit aesthetic theory identifies as the defining gesture of Dalit literature: the refusal to accept the dominant culture's assessment of who is guilty, who is criminal, who deserves punishment. The Paswan community man who is accused of being at the wrong place in the wrong time; the Dalit woman labelled 'characterless' for rescuing an abandoned infant; the poor boy whose school education is interrupted by a rich man's manipulation — these are the collection's 'mujrims', and the collection's project is to invert the juridical verdict, to show that the real mujrim is the system, not the person it accuses.

Structurally, the collection's sixteen stories form a panorama of Mithila's social reality: from gender (Sunanda), to water rights and caste (Solkanama Pokhar), to moral corruption (Karmaak Fal), to caste violence (Girhast Ghar Par Giddh), to education and caste identity (Tetar Das, Kodar Chhap), to family solidarity (Sahodara), to class exploitation (Gariibka Jinaagi), to collective labour organisation (Shramadani Banh), to spatial caste segregation (Dachhinwari Tol), to addiction and gender violence (Pagla Pul), to social reform (Vidhwa Vivaah, Vridhashram, Dostak Biaahe), to institutional hypocrisy (Maanavtaak Pujari), and finally to Dalit sainthood and belonging (Bhagwanpur).

## 3.2 Key Stories and Their Analysis

### *3.2.1 Sunanda — Gender, Moral Courage, and Village Hypocrisy*

The opening story 'Sunanda' is one of the collection's finest achievements. Sunanda is the educated daughter of Raman Master — an M.A. and B.Ed. holder who lives in a Patna hostel preparing for the BPSC competitive examination. Returning home late at night in rain, she discovers a newborn infant abandoned by the roadside, wraps it in her shawl, and brings it home. The village immediately brands her as morally fallen: 'Raman Master ki beti ki kumaare bacha bhaile hen' (Raman Master's daughter had a child out of wedlock). The village gossip machine — dramatically rendered through the voices of 'Bhutwali' and 'Rupauliwali', two neighbour women who carry and amplify the slander — drives both the social condemnation and (eventually) the revelation of truth.

The story's narrative architecture follows the classical structure of anagnorisis (recognition/discovery) — the reveal that the abandoned infant belongs not to Sunanda but to Ranjana, the daughter of the 'pratigishtha' (prestigious) household of Sujit Majhlik, who had become pregnant and abandoned the child to protect the family's honour. The irony is structurally perfect: Sunanda, who committed the act of compassion (picking up the abandoned child), is branded criminal ('mujrim'); Ranjana, who committed the act of abandonment, is protected by social and economic privilege.

From Aristotle's Poetics, the story employs both peripeteia (reversal of fortune — Sunanda's compassionate act reverses into social condemnation) and anagnorisis (recognition — the discovery of the truth about the infant's parentage). The story's moral structure is also recognisably Kantian: Sunanda's act is the categorical imperative in action — she treats the abandoned infant as an end in itself, not as a means — while the village's response demonstrates the consequences of treating persons as instruments of social reputation management.

### *3.2.2 Solkanama Pokhar — Water, Caste, and Crisis*

'Solkanama Pokhar' (The Solkanama Pond) is the collection's most overtly allegorical piece. A village faces a water crisis: all the tube wells and hand-pumps have dried up. There is one source of water — the Solkanama pond, which belongs to the Solkanama neighbourhood (a Dalit neighbourhood). Upper-caste villagers have refused to use this pond out of caste prejudice ('Solkanama Tolka lok ka gharka paaniye na chalait chhai

takhana pokharika kon baat' — even the water in Solkanama Tol people's own homes does not work, so what of the pond?). The story reaches its crisis when fire breaks out in the village, and the fire engine needs water from — the Solkanama pond. The pond that was 'impure' for drinking becomes the life-saving water source in the emergency.

This is parable at its most economical. The fire-water plot functions like the classical folk-tale structure of the 'reversed situation': the thing that was despised (the Dalit neighbourhood's water) becomes the saving resource in the moment of crisis. The story implicitly asks: if this water was pure enough to save your house from fire, was it ever truly impure? The story answers this question with structural irony rather than direct statement — another instance of the vakrokti (oblique expression) that Kuntaka identifies as the hallmark of literary excellence. The 'purity' of water is revealed as a social construct, not a natural fact; and the crisis reveals the community's interdependence that caste prejudice had obscured.

### *3.2.3 Girhast Ghar Par Giddh — Caste Violence and Collective Resistance*

'Girhast Ghar Par Giddh' (Vultures Over the Landlord's House) is the collection's most directly confrontational story about caste violence. In Daulatpur village, Dalit youths are forcibly removed from a 'shraddh' feast (ancestor-remembrance ceremony). Later, one is beaten for entering the temple. The Dalit community responds with collective action: they refuse to perform their traditional caste-assigned service of removing dead cattle from the landlords' properties. As animals begin dying from disease and the carcasses accumulate, vultures circle over the landlord's house — the story's title-image and its central metaphor of social decomposition.

The vultures are not merely literal scavengers; they are the Dhvani-image that resonates across multiple levels of meaning simultaneously: the literal vultures that appear when the Dalit carcass-removers refuse their traditional role; the metaphorical vultures of caste society that circle over the decomposing social order; and the implied critique of the landowning class that has become, in its refusal of social justice, as dependent on Dalit labour as the scavenger birds are on death. The story ends with the panchayat's intervention and a declaration of equal rights — a resolution that is optimistic without being utopian.

From Brecht's Epic Theatre perspective, this story employs the Verfremdungseffekt (alienation effect) by making the conventional — the Dalit

community's 'traditional service' of carcass removal — strange through the act of its withdrawal. The audience/reader is made to see what was invisible: the labour that makes the upper-caste household function is Dalit labour, and its withdrawal exposes the household's actual dependence. This is precisely the Brechtian technique of making social relations visible by interrupting their 'naturalised' flow.

### *3.2.4 Tetar Das — Scholarship, Faith, and Caste Identity*

'Tetar Das' is the collection's most emotionally complex and philosophically rich story. A boy named Tetra ('Lootna' by village nickname, because his mother died in childbirth and he was considered an ill omen) grows up to become a Sanskrit scholar, a saint-figure revered as 'Tetar Das', whose pravachans (discourses) attract thousands. When the proposal arises that he become Mahant (head) of the Govindpur Math (religious institution), caste opposition erupts — he is a Dalit, and the Math has never had a Dalit Mahant.

This story dramatises one of the most devastating ironies of the caste system: the person whose spiritual accomplishment would qualify them for the highest religious honour is disqualified by birth. Tetar Das's response is devastating in its spiritual logic — he withdraws entirely, returns to his village, leaving behind all the recognition he has achieved. This withdrawal is not defeat; it is the expression of a dignity that refuses to participate in an institution that would use him while refusing to fully honour him.

The story engages with a rich tradition of Dalit saint narratives — Ravidas (Raidas), Kabir, Chokhamela — subaltern saint-figures who were simultaneously revered for their spiritual achievement and discriminated against for their caste identity. Tetar Das's situation recapitulates this historical pattern in a contemporary setting, demonstrating that the caste system's refusal of Dalit spiritual authority has not ended despite constitutional protections and formal religious equality.

### *3.2.5 Kodar Chhap (The Hoe-Print/Thumbprint)*

'Kodar Chhap' (literally 'hoe-print', but the story uses the term to mean 'thumbprint/mark of the illiterate') is the collection's most politically sharp examination of democratic corruption. Folta — a criminal-type figure — exploits the reservation system meant for Dalit communities by running an illiterate Dalit woman (Fekhani, wife of the labourer Mussba) as a 'proxy candidate' for the post of Mukhiya (village head). Using alcohol, money, and threats, Folta wins the election with Fekhani as his front person. Fekhani

remains in name only the Mukhiya while Folta controls all financial decisions, siphoning off government scheme money and MNREGA funds.

When the investigation comes, Fekhani testifies truthfully — that she 'only gave thumbprints' ('kodar chhap' — the hoe-print of the illiterate). Both Folta and Fekhani are arrested. The story's moral structure is complex: Fekhani is simultaneously victim (of Folta's manipulation) and participant (in the corruption), and the justice system treats her as both simultaneously. The 'kodar chhap' — the thumbprint of the illiterate — becomes the story's central image of the Dalit woman's double vulnerability: illiteracy makes her exploitable, and her exploitability makes her legally guilty of the crime she was manipulated into enabling.

### *3.2.6 Dostak Biaahe (Friend's Wedding)*

This story is the collection's most autobiographically inflected — written in the first person, it narrates the experience of a Dalit narrator who accompanies his friend's wedding party, only to be humiliated when the bride's family objects to his presence because he is Dalit ('Oi lokani dalit jaatik chhi'). The narrator leaves the wedding silently, spending the night alone. The resolution comes only after the narrator has obtained government employment — at which point all barriers disappear: 'Aab ham sarkari naukri karai chhi. Neek paika aamdani achhi. Aab ham juto pahirane dostar gosaainho ghar jaai chhi ta kiyoa ne bajait achhi aa ne rokaait achhi.'

This resolution — that economic status and government employment remove caste barriers — is simultaneously an observation and a critique. The story does not celebrate this resolution; it observes it with clear-eyed bitterness. The final sentence — 'Aise ham anubhav kelau je konahu bi jaatik lok hue ja okara aarthik sthiti neek chhai, maane sampann chhai ta okara lel ketauwe jai-abaime kono rok-tok nai chhai. Sabha darwaja khujal chhai' (From this I experienced that whatever caste a person belongs to, if their economic situation is good, meaning they are prosperous, then there is no barrier to their going anywhere. All doors are open) — is the story's most devastating social observation: economic prosperity can temporarily override caste discrimination, but this is not justice — it is the market's conditional tolerance, which would be withdrawn if the economic condition changed.

### *3.2.7 Bhagwanpur — Humanist Sainthood and Caste's Final Barrier*

The closing story 'Bhagwanpur' is the collection's most formally accomplished piece and its final statement about the relationship between

humanist goodness and caste structure. Bhagwan Lal Das — whose very name invokes the divine — is an M.A. graduate from a Dalit community who chooses to remain unmarried, dedicating his entire life and resources to helping the poor: financing weddings, funding education, providing interest-free loans, distributing his land to the landless. He becomes a BDO (Block Development Officer) and uses his salary entirely for community welfare. When he dies, a final irony confronts him: the upper-caste cremation ground refuses to cremate him there, because he is Dalit.

The story's resolution — that his servant Ram Lal cremates him on his own property (his 'gharaadi') — is not a triumphant resolution but a quiet, dignified one. Bhagwan Lal Das is cremated on his own land, the land that remains after he has given everything else away. The village is eventually named 'Bhagwanpur' after him. This posthumous naming — the ultimate act of social recognition, giving the village his name — arrives only after death has removed the barrier of caste that could not be crossed in life. The irony is the story's final word: the man whose life embodied the values of human service ('maanavataak pujari') is denied full social belonging until he is no longer present to inhabit it.

## 3.3 Narrative Craft and Moral Structure

Across the sixteen stories of Mujrim, Paswan employs a consistent narrative craft characterised by: economy of means (the stories are brief, without excess description or psychological interiority beyond what the social situation requires); moral clarity without didacticism (the stories know what is right and wrong, but the exposition of this comes through narrative structure rather than authorial commentary); community-embedded characterisation (individuals are always placed within their caste-community context, never presented as isolated individuals); and resolution through collective action or ironic reversal rather than through individual heroism.

This narrative method is what Georg Lukács would call 'typical' realism: the characters are not average in the sense of mediocre, but 'typical' in the sense of embodying the social-historical forces of their time and place in their specific individuality. Each character is a particular person — Sunanda the MA-holder preparing for BPSC, Tetar Das the Sanskrit scholar, Fekhani the illiterate labour wife, Bhagwan Lal Das the celibate civil servant-saint — while simultaneously embodying a social type that illuminates the structural conditions of their community.

# Chapter IV: Critical Frameworks Applied

## 4.1 Bharata's Natyashastra — Rasa, Abhinaya, and Social Drama

Bharata's Natyashastra (c. 200 BCE-200 CE) provides the classical Indian critical framework within which Paswan's literary achievement must be understood. The rasa theory — the identification of eight (or nine) aesthetic emotional flavours — applies to his work with specific precision. The dominant rasas across Virnit Ras and Mujrim are: vira-rasa (heroic resolution) — the dominant rasa of the protest poetry, which moves from the recognition of injustice toward the assertion of rights and resistance; karuna-rasa (compassion/pathos) — the dominant rasa of the short stories, which generate the aesthetic experience of empathetic recognition of suffering; raudra-rasa (righteous anger) — operative in both the poetry and the story 'Girhast Ghar Par Giddh', where the Dalit community's collective refusal generates justified fury; and adbhuta-rasa (wonder) — present in the stories that achieve ironic revelation, particularly 'Solkanama Pokhar' and 'Bhagwanpur', where the conventional social world is inverted to expose its hidden truths.

The Natyashastra's concept of abhinaya (representation through expression) is relevant to the question of narrative voice in Mujrim. Bharata identifies four modes of abhinaya: angika (bodily), vachika (verbal), aharya (costumed/visual), and sattvika (emotional/psychological). Paswan's narrative fiction operates primarily through the vachika (verbal) mode — the specific dialects and registers of his characters' speech are the primary carriers of social identity and dramatic meaning. When the village women in 'Sunanda' gossip in their specific Maithili register, when Fekhani's husband speaks in his specific working-class idiom, when Bhagwan Lal Das speaks in the measured tones of the educated civil servant — these verbal registers are not mere stylistic details but the theatrical equivalent of aharya: they costume the characters socially, marking their position in the social hierarchy.

## 4.2 Navya Nyaya Epistemology and Literary Knowledge

Gangesa Upadhyaya's four pramanas map onto the specific epistemic dimensions of Paswan's literary production with precise relevance. Pratyaksha (direct perception) is the foundation of both the poetry and the fiction: the water crisis in 'Solkanama Pokhar' is observed directly; the migration poem 'Gelhe Ghar Chhi' reads the bullocks' pain as a direct perceptual sign of the social

condition. Anumana (inference) operates in the stories' moral and structural logic: from the visible injustice of caste discrimination (the smoke), the stories infer the hidden fire of structural violence. Upamana (analogy/comparison) operates through the stories' parabolic structure — each story presents a specific situation that illuminates a general social truth through analogy. Shabda (verbal testimony) is the epistemological mode of the poetry's social critique: Paswan's verse functions as testimony, bearing witness to what has been lived and seen.

The Navya Nyaya concept of avacchedakatva (delimitation/qualification) is relevant to understanding Paswan's narrative economy. Each story precisely delimits its social domain — 'Sunanda' is delimited to the domain of gender and village reputation; 'Solkanama Pokhar' to water and caste purity; 'Girhast Ghar Par Giddh' to caste violence and collective resistance. This precision of delimitation prevents the stories from becoming generalised social commentary and gives each one the specific, datable, locally-grounded quality of testimony.

## 4.3 Dalit Aesthetics (Sharankumar Limbale)

Sharankumar Limbale's Towards an Aesthetic of Dalit Literature (1996; English trans. Alok Mukherjee, 2004) provides the most directly applicable theoretical framework for evaluating Paswan's literary achievement. Limbale argues that Dalit literature is defined by 'authenticity of experience' rather than formal aesthetic criteria derived from the upper-caste literary tradition, and that Dalit autobiography functions as 'community autobiography' — the individual's story is simultaneously the community's story.

Both of Paswan's works confirm Limbale's formulation. Virnit Ras is explicitly community poetry — even its first-person voice ('Ham dalit chhi' — We are Dalit) uses the first person plural, asserting communal rather than individual identity. The Mujrim stories are equally community-oriented: their characters are not psychological individuals pursuing private destinies but community representatives whose specific situations illuminate collective social conditions. This is community literature in the precise sense Limbale describes.

Limbale also argues that Dalit literature must go beyond documenting suffering to assert dignity and resistance. Paswan's work fulfills this imperative: the protest poems of Virnit Ras are not laments but challenges; the stories of Mujrim end not with acceptance of injustice but with collective resistance (Girhast Ghar Par Giddh), institutional exposure (Kodar Chhap),

moral revelation (Sunanda, Bhagwanpur), and dignified withdrawal (Tetar Das). The dignity asserted is not triumphant but resilient — the persistence of moral seriousness in the face of social obstruction.

## 4.4 Protest Poetry Traditions — Langston Hughes, Namdeo Dhasal, and Paswan

Umesh Paswan's protest poetry participates in a global tradition of subaltern political verse that includes Langston Hughes's Harlem Renaissance poetry ('I, too, sing America'; 'The Negro Speaks of Rivers'), Pablo Neruda's social poetry, and — most directly relevant — Namdeo Dhasal's Golpitha (1972), the foundational collection of Dalit Panthers poetry in Marathi.

The comparison with Langston Hughes is illuminating. Hughes's strategy of claiming American cultural belonging — asserting African American identity as central to American national identity, not marginal to it — has a direct parallel in Paswan's poetry, which claims Maithili cultural belonging ('Maithila mahaan', 'Paavana bhoomi Maithilaak') for the Dalit community while simultaneously challenging the exclusions that have denied that belonging. 'Ham Maithili chhi' (We are Maithili) — the assertion of Maithili cultural identity by a Dalit poet — is the exact parallel of Hughes's 'I, too, am America.'

Namdeo Dhasal's Golpitha — the raw, visceral poetry of the Bombay red-light district, which combines caste anger with erotic imagery and revolutionary politics in a style of unprecedented formal transgression — represents a more radical aesthetic model than Paswan's. Paswan's protest poetry is more restrained, more accessible, more folk-lyric in its rhythms than Dhasal's experimental Marathi verse. But they share the fundamental impulse: the refusal of aesthetic passivity in the face of social violence, the insistence that poetry must serve justice.

## 4.5 Social Realism and Georg Lukács

The Mujrim stories' narrative method engages with the tradition of social realism that Georg Lukács theorised in Studies in European Realism (1950) and The Historical Novel (1962). Lukács's concept of 'typicality' — the literary representation of characters who, in their specific individuality, embody the social-historical forces of their time — applies precisely to Paswan's story characters: each is a specific person (Sunanda the BPSC

aspirant, Fekhani the illiterate labour wife, Bhagwan Lal Das the celibate civil servant-saint) who simultaneously embodies a social type.

The tragic closure of Lukács's realist novel — the refusal to impose false consolation on social contradictions — is present in Mujrim as ironic resolution rather than tragic defeat. The stories end with recognition (Sunanda's vindication), collective resistance (Girhast Ghar Par Giddh's boycott), or bitter irony (Bhagwanpur's posthumous naming). These are not triumphant resolutions, but they are not mere laments either: they are the realistic mapping of the available possibilities within the social constraints that the stories document.

## 4.6 Feminist Intersectionality

Kimberlé Crenshaw's theory of intersectionality — the compounding of multiple forms of oppression (caste, class, gender) — is enacted in Paswan's work through the specific attention he pays to women characters who experience all three simultaneously. Sunanda (gender + caste + class), Fekhani (gender + illiteracy + exploitation), Mithilaak Naari (women's agricultural labour + domestic oppression + cultural transmission), and the domestic violence poem 'Maraike Man Ta Sagme Hardi Nai' (from Safi's work, but paralleled in Paswan's 'Dachhinwari Tol') all depict women who navigate the intersection of caste, gender, and class with varying degrees of agency.

The story 'Vidhva Vivah' (Widow Remarriage) addresses the specific situation of widows in Maithili society — women who are not merely economically vulnerable (the loss of the husband's income) but socially stigmatised (widowhood in many Hindu traditions carries ritual pollution) and denied the fundamental right to remarry. Paswan's engagement with this issue connects him to the long tradition of social reform in Maithili literature (Harimohan Jha's Kanyadan engaged with the dowry system in the 1940s) while applying a specifically Dalit perspective: for Dalit widows, the economic vulnerability is more acute and the social ostracism more severe, because they lack the economic resources and social networks that upper-caste widows can sometimes access.

# Chapter V: Comparative Study — Paswan and Dalit Writers across Languages

## 5.1 The Comparative Framework

Umesh Paswan's work can be situated within the broader tradition of Dalit literature across Indian languages — a tradition that, as scholars have established, began in Marathi with the autobiographies and poetry of the 1970s-80s (Daya Pawar, Namdeo Dhasal, Sharankumar Limbale), spread to Hindi (Omprakash Valmiki, Mohandas Naimishrai), Tamil (Bama), Kannada (Siddalingaiah), Bengali (Manoranjan Byapari), and now — through Sandeep Kumar Safi's autobiography and Umesh Paswan's poetry and fiction — to Maithili. The comparative table below maps Paswan against three major Dalit writers across languages.

**Comparative Matrix: Umesh Paswan and Dalit Writers across Languages**

| Criterion | Umesh Paswan — Virnit Ras & Mujrim (Maithili) | Omprakash Valmiki — Joothan/Poems (Hindi) | Namdeo Dhasal — Golpitha (Marathi) | Bama — Karukku/Sangati (Tamil) |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Caste/ Community | Paswan (Dusadh) — Dalit, Madhubani, Bihar | Chuhra (Valmiki) — UP sweeper caste | Mahar — Maharashtra; Dalit Panthers founder | Paraiyar — Dalit-Christian woman, Tamil Nadu |
| Primary Genres | Poetry collection (Virnit Ras, 2012) + Short story collection (Mujrim, 2026) | Autobiography + poetry; Dalit literary criticism | Radical Dalit poetry; prose manifestos | Autobiographical fiction + short stories |

| | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Poetic Register | Direct, accessible, social-protest verse; Maithili folk rhythms + civic anger | Hindi literary register; Ambedkarite political assertion | Experimental, raw, erotic-political; Marathi urban slang | Oral Tamil register; spiritual-feminist |
| Thematic Core | Caste violence, labour exploitation, political corruption, migration, women's dignity, communal solidarity, Mithila ecology | Untouchability, school discrimination, manual scavenging, Ambedkar's transformative influence | Urban slum life, sexual exploitation, State violence, revolutionary rage | Gender + caste intersection, Dalit-Christian identity, rural suffering, faith |
| Narrative Mode in Fiction | Social-realist parables; moral tale structure; community-embedded plots; resolution through collective action or | No separate fiction — autobiography is the dominant form | No separate fiction — poetry as communal narrative | Autobiographical fiction; fragmented memory structure |

| | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | irony | | | |
| Navya Nyaya Pramana | Pratyaksha of Paswan community life; shabda-pramana of oral social testimony | Pratyaksha of chuhra experience; anumana of caste structure | Vivid pratyaksha of slum sensorium; inference of systemic violence | Vyanjana (suggestion) of gendered Dalit suffering |
| Ambedkar's Role | Implicit constitutional aspiration; reservation debate in 'Kodar Chhap' | Explicit: Ambedkar transforms Valmiki into speaking subject | Explicit: Dalit Panthers; anti-Brahmin revolutionary ethos | Implicit: faith and community solidarity as resistance |
| Western Parallel | Langston Hughes (social lyric), Premchand (village realism), Rabindranath Tagore (humanist parable) | Frantz Fanon (anti-colonial anger), Frederick Douglass (slave autobiography) | Allen Ginsberg (transgressive lyric), Mayakovsky (revolutionary voice) | Gabriel García Márquez (magic realism + social tragedy) |
| Institutional Position | Videha Parallel Literature Movement; Pallavi Prakashan | Mainstream + Dalit institutional recognition; Hindi Akademi | Dalit Panthers; Maharashtra state recognition | Independent Tamil Dalit women's writing tradition |

| | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| | (2026) | awards | | |

## 5.2 Paswan and Omprakash Valmiki

The comparison with Omprakash Valmiki — the most prominent Hindi Dalit writer — reveals both convergences and significant divergences. Both emerge from hereditary service castes (Valmiki from the sweeper caste, Paswan from the Dusadh/watchman community) of North India; both engage with education as both aspiration and disappointment; both write in the Ambedkarite tradition of rights assertion. The key divergence is one of form: Valmiki's most important work is the autobiography Joothan (1997), in which the personal narrative of trauma and transformation is the primary literary vehicle. Paswan's most important works are a poetry collection and a short story collection — he comes to the literary tradition through lyric assertion (Virnit Ras) and social parable (Mujrim) rather than through autobiographical testimony. This formal difference is significant: autobiography places the individual 'I' at the centre; Paswan's forms — poetry and short stories — tend toward the collective and the representative, placing the community's experience at the centre even when using a first-person narrative voice.

## 5.3 Paswan and Namdeo Dhasal

The comparison with Namdeo Dhasal — whose Golpitha (1972) is the founding text of Marathi Dalit protest poetry and arguably the most formally radical Dalit literary text in any Indian language — reveals the range of aesthetic strategies available to Dalit poets. Dhasal's poetry is transgressive, formal risk-taking, deliberately uncomfortable: it places the language of the red-light district, the slum, and the street in the literary space previously reserved for Brahmin cultural production. Paswan's poetry is more accessible, more pedagogically oriented — it aims to be heard and understood by a broad community audience, not only by literary sophisticates. Both are protest poetry, but Dhasal protests through aesthetic disruption while Paswan protests through clarity and emotional directness.

This difference reflects different social-literary contexts: Dhasal wrote in the context of the Dalit Panthers movement, which was deliberately confrontational with the Bombay Brahminical literary establishment; Paswan writes in the context of the Videha Parallel Literature Movement, which has chosen the strategy of institutional building (the archive, the journal, the digital

library) rather than frontal assault on the establishment. The different strategic contexts produce different aesthetic strategies.

### 5.4 Paswan and Bama

The comparison with Bama — the Tamil Dalit woman writer whose Karukku (1992) combines autobiography, social critique, and spiritual reflection in a fragmented, oral-inflected form — reveals the gender dimension of Dalit literary production. Bama's work is explicitly gendered: she writes as a Dalit woman, for whom the triple burden of caste, class, and gender oppression is the defining condition. Paswan writes as a Dalit man — he is attentive to women's conditions (as in 'Mithilaak Naari', 'Sunanda', 'Vidhva Vivah') but writes from a male perspective, not a female one.

The Maithili Dalit literary tradition identified in this series of critical appreciations — Sandeep Kumar Safi's autobiography and Umesh Paswan's poetry and fiction — is so far exclusively male. The absence of Maithili Dalit women's writing as published literary production is the most urgent gap in the tradition, and Paswan's sympathetic engagement with women's conditions in his fiction is the best pointer to what such writing, when it arrives, will need to address.

## Chapter VI: Synthesis — Umesh Paswan's Place in Literary History

### 6.1 The Double Achievement: Poetry and Fiction

Umesh Paswan's literary achievement is unique within the Maithili Dalit tradition for its generic range: where Sandeep Kumar Safi has produced a hybrid volume (autobiography + poetry + micro-fiction) and where Rajdeo Mandal has produced primarily fiction (with some poetry), Paswan has produced a full poetry collection and a full short story collection, making him the most formally diverse of the Maithili Dalit writers in the Videha parallel tradition. This generic range is not merely a quantitative achievement; it reflects a literary personality of genuine versatility — one that can move between the lyric-political register of protest poetry and the social-realist register of morality-tale fiction.

The fourteen-year gap between Virnit Ras (2012) and Mujrim (2026) also represents a significant literary development. The poetry collection is formally more direct, more declaratory, more immediately rhetorical — the

work of a writer finding his voice and establishing his social concerns. The stories of Mujrim demonstrate a more fully developed narrative craft — the ability to sustain multiple characters, to construct ironic reversals, to embed social critique in storytelling without allowing the critique to overwhelm the narrative. This development from poetry to fiction is itself a literary history: the poet who has learned to tell stories.

## 6.2 The 'Mujrim' as Critical Concept

The title concept of Mujrim — the accused who is not guilty, or whose guilt is the product of the system's imposition rather than their own moral failure — is Paswan's most important contribution to Maithili Dalit literary thought. It provides a conceptual framework for understanding not just the sixteen stories but the entire social situation of the Dalit community in Mithila: a community that has been rendered 'mujrim' by the caste system — accused of impurity, guilt, inferiority — without having committed any crime. The mujrim is the subject who has been wrongly accused, and the recovery of dignity for the mujrim is the project of restoring justice.

Applied through Navya Nyaya: the social label 'mujrim' is a bhrama — a false cognition — imposed by caste hierarchy's self-serving epistemology. Paswan's fiction, by showing that the real guilt lies elsewhere (with Sujit Majhlik's family in 'Sunanda', with Folta in 'Kodar Chhap', with the caste-system in 'Tetar Das'), establishes the prama — the valid cognition — that corrects this bhrama. The sixteen stories are sixteen exercises in epistemological justice: restoring valid cognition where false cognition has been imposed.

## 6.3 The Videha Movement's Achievement

The Videha Digital Library's archiving of Virnit Ras and Mujrim (alongside Sandeep Kumar Safi's Baishakh Me Dalan Par, Rajdeo Mandal's Hamar Tol and other works) has created what did not previously exist: a publicly accessible, globally readable archive of Maithili Dalit literature. This archiving is a cultural act of the highest importance. It means that Umesh Paswan's poetry and fiction can be read by scholars of Dalit literature, South Asian studies, comparative literature, and postcolonial theory anywhere in the world — not merely by Maithili-reading specialists.

The Videha movement's manifesto — 'Manushimih Samskritam' — has found its fullest literary expression in writers like Umesh Paswan, whose work insists that humans come first in culture: before caste, before tradition,

before the aesthetics of the established literary order. 'Virnit Ras' — the extracted, distilled aesthetic essence — is what Paswan has found in the lived reality of the Dusadh community's life, and what he offers to the Maithili literary tradition as its most necessary supplement.

### 6.4 Concluding Assessment

Umesh Paswan stands as one of the most important Dalit literary voices in the Maithili language — a poet whose protest verse achieves genuine literary force through the combination of folk rhythmic accessibility and social-political clarity, and a fiction writer whose sixteen stories constitute a panoramic and morally serious engagement with the social realities of Mithila's Dalit communities. His work, considered alongside that of Sandeep Kumar Safi and within the larger frame of the Videha Parallel Literature Movement, demonstrates that the Maithili Dalit literary tradition — though younger than its counterparts in Marathi, Hindi, and Tamil — has achieved a maturity and diversity that ensures its continuation and its importance.

Applied through the Navya Nyaya framework: Virnit Ras and Mujrim together establish the prama of Paswan community life — its specific social texture, its moral seriousness, its cultural richness, and its political claims — against the bhrama of mainstream Maithili culture's assumption that Dalit experience either does not exist or is not worthy of literary representation. In Gangesa's terms, this is the work of literary epistemology: replacing false cognition with valid cognition through the rigorous and patient attention to the actual object of knowledge. And the object of Umesh Paswan's knowledge — the Paswan community's life in contemporary rural Mithila — has, through his poetry and fiction, finally found its literary form.

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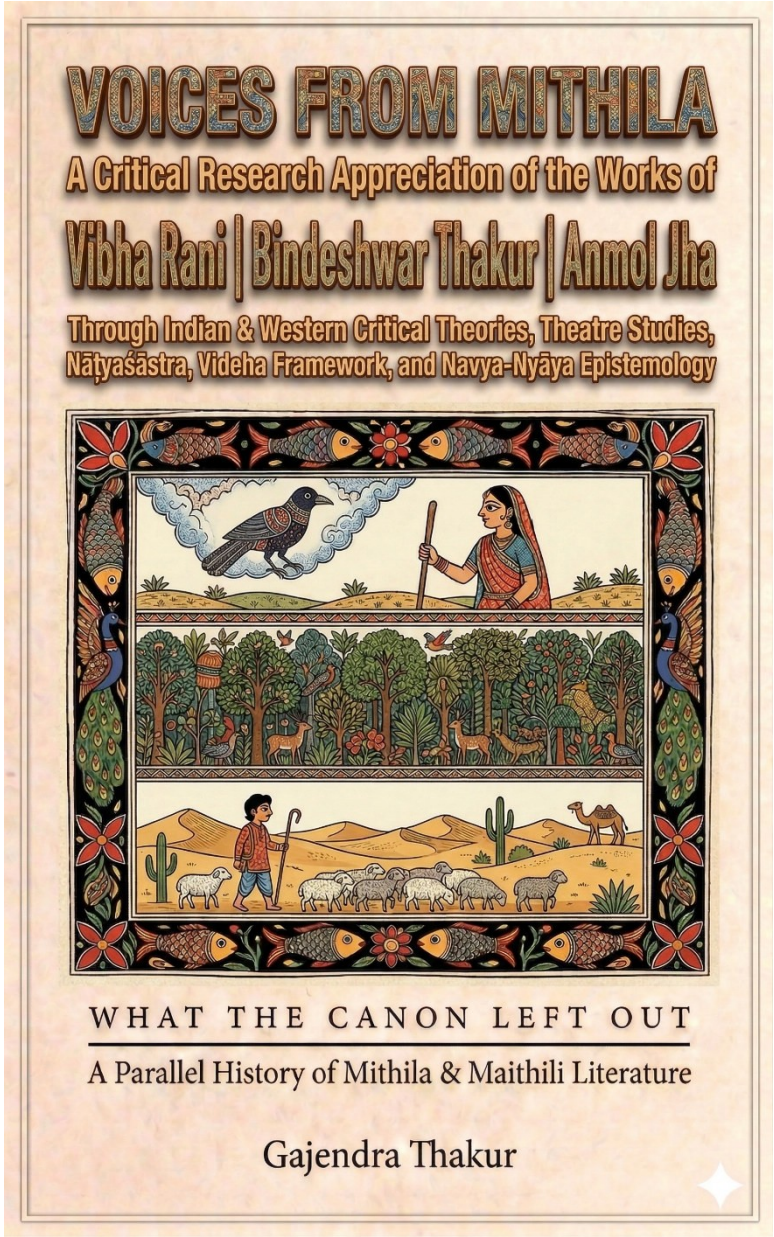
*'Dalit upejhit vargak pahichan chhi Virnit Ras.' — Umesh Paswan*

**LESSON 092 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**




# VOICES FROM MITHILA

A Critical Research Appreciation of the Works of

**Vibha Rani | Bindeshwar Thakur | Anmol Jha**

*Through Indian & Western Critical Theories, Theatre Studies, Nāṭyaśāstra, Videha Framework, and Navya-Nyāya Epistemology*

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## I. Preface and Methodological Orientation

Maithili literature occupies a singular position in the South Asian literary imagination. It is the language in which Vidyapati composed his immortal padāvalis; the language in which Jyotirishwara Ṭhākura gave us the first prose encyclopaedia in any north Indian tongue; the language whose Tirhuta script (Mithilākṣara) carries memories of the ancient kingdom of Videha. Yet for much of modern literary history, Maithili has struggled against institutional marginalisation—treated as a dialect of Hindi, underrepresented in academic curricula, and cleaved between two nations, India and Nepal, whose literary

establishments have paid differential and often inequitable attention to its practitioners.

The three writers studied in this monograph—Vibha Rani, Bindeshwar Thakur, and Anmol Jha—represent distinct yet intersecting trajectories within contemporary Maithili letters. Vibha Rani is a national-level dramatist, fiction writer, and performer who writes in both Maithili and Hindi; her plays Bhāg Rau and Balchandā, published by Shruti Prakashan and archived on videha.co.in, constitute the primary textual corpus for this study. Bindeshwar Thakur, based in the Gulf Maithili diaspora (Qatar), brought out Nepālak Nor Marubhūmi Me (2014, Shruti Prakashan)—a composite volume of ghazals, sher-o-shāirī, laghukathā, bihani kathā, and poems—that encodes the anguish of migrant labour within classical Maithili prosodic forms. Anmol Jha is a researcher, critic, and short-story writer whose collection Samay Sākṣī Ṭhik (laghukathā) and the monumental 745-page CCRT Senior Fellowship research report on Samakālīn Maithilī Bāl Sāhityak Vivechanātmak Adhyayan (2023–25) provide a critical and pedagogical anchor for the study of contemporary Maithili literature, especially children's writing.

The methodological architecture of this study is deliberately pluralist. We draw on four broad critical traditions: first, classical Indian aesthetic theory (Bharata's Nāṭyaśāstra, the rasa-dhvani tradition of Ānandavardhana and Abhinavagupta, Kuntaka's vakrokti, and Aucitya-vicāra-carcā of Kṣemendra); second, the Navya-Nyāya epistemological framework of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya of Mithila, whose Tattvacintāmaṇi provides a precision-language model for knowledge-claims that we apply to generic and modal questions in Maithili prose and drama; third, Western critical theory (Aristotle's Poetics, Brecht's epic theatre, feminist criticism, postcolonial theory, diasporic studies, ecocriticism, and the sociology of literature); and fourth, the Videha Parallel History Framework developed by Gajendra Thakur, editor of Videha eJournal (ISSN 2229-547X), which interrogates the dominant caste-and-institution narrative of Maithili literary history and rehabilitates excluded voices.

# II. Contextual Frameworks: Theories Applied

## II.A Classical Indian Literary Criticism

The foundational text of Indian poetics is Bharata Muni's Nāṭyaśāstra (c. 200 BCE–200 CE), a comprehensive treatise on dramatic composition, performance, staging, music, and dance. For the purposes of reading Vibha Rani's Maithili plays, three concepts from the Nāṭyaśāstra are especially productive.

### *Rasa Theory*

Bharata enumerates eight rasas—śṛṅgāra (love/beauty), hāsya (humour), karuṇa (pathos), raudra (fury), vīra (heroism), bhayānaka (terror), bībhatsa (disgust), and adbhuta (wonder)—to which the later tradition adds śānta (tranquillity) as a ninth. Each rasa is produced by the conjunction of vibhāvas (determinants), anubhāvas (consequents), and vyābhicāri-bhāvas (transitory emotional states). A play achieves rasotpatti (production of rasa) when the audience undergoes a kind of generalised, depersonalised affective experience—sādhāraṇīkaraṇa—distinct from private emotion.

Vibha Rani's Bhāg Rau (Run Away) is a Maithili play set entirely in the milieu of street children, beggars, police brutality, and urban destitution. The dominant rasa is karuṇa, but Rani orchestrates a complex affective ecology: hāsya erupts in the banter of the three child beggars (Chanrā, Gobarā, Jhunmā) only to be extinguished by the raudra of police violence; adbhuta surfaces when Mangtū, the limbless protagonist, is revealed as a literate reader of newspapers; and a residual śṛṅgāra trembles in Mangtū's dream-sequence in Act II when his amputated limbs momentarily return in a vision of wholeness. The play's sthāyibhāva (dominant emotion) is śoka (grief), yet Rani refuses the consolations of śānta-rasa, ending instead with a unison chant—'Bhaḍab vijaya-path par, racab nit navīn abhiyān' (We shall march the victory path, creating ever-new campaigns)—that re-channels grief into vīra-rasa (heroism).

### *Dhvani and Vyañjanā*

Ānandavardhana's Dhvanyāloka (9th century CE) proposes dhvani (suggestion, resonance) as the 'soul of poetry' (kāvyasyātmā). Vyañjanā (suggestive meaning) transcends both abhidhā (denotative meaning) and lakṣaṇā (secondary/figurative meaning) to produce the highest aesthetic pleasure. Abhinavagupta's commentary Locana deepens this: dhvani is not merely a trope but an ontological claim that poetic language operates on multiple semantic levels simultaneously.

In Balchandā, Vibha Rani's mono-drama for and about female foeticide and the suppressed feminine, dhvani operates at every level. The single female performer cycles through daughter, wife, mother-in-law, journalist, and the unborn girl-child. The title Balchandā—a Maithili female name meaning 'young moon'—vibrates with dhvani: the moon is both feminine (candra is grammatically feminine in Maithili poetic convention following Vidyapati) and absent/suppressed (the play literalises female erasure). The performer's repeated gesture of placing the index finger on her own navel—representing the womb, the child, the absent moon—is a pure anubhāva whose vyañjanā encompasses the entire cultural matrix of stri-dveṣa (misogyny) without being reducible to it.

### *Aucitya (Decorum/Propriety)*

Kṣemendra's Aucitya-vicāra-carcā (11th century) argues that aucitya—the decorous fit between form, content, and context—is the supreme literary virtue. An unaucitous metaphor or dramatic device destroys aesthetic experience even when technically accomplished. This criterion is especially relevant for evaluating Vibha Rani's decision to stage the politically incendiary content of Bhāg Rau in a Maithili linguistic register that itself carries cultural prestige. The play's language is contemporary colloquial Maithili—film-song references, bazaar idiom, the jargon of police-bureaucratic Hindi—yet it is framed by a literary Maithili stage direction rhetoric. This layering constitutes an aucita (proper) translation of street life into theatrical space without either romanticising poverty or lapsing into social-realist flatness.

## II.B Bharata's Nāṭyaśāstra: Drama Theory

The Nāṭyaśāstra's theory of drama encompasses: (1) the pañcasandhi structure (five stages of plot—mukha, pratimukha, garbha, vimarśa, nirvahaṇa); (2) the classification of heroes (dhīrodātta, dhīralalita, dhīroddhata, dhīrapraśānta); (3) the ten types of drama (rūpaka) and their sub-varieties; (4) the four abhinayas (representational modes: āṅgika/bodily, vācika/verbal, āhārya/costumed, sāttvika/psychological); and (5) the concept of nāṭyadharmi (theatrical/stylised) versus lokadharmi (naturalistic/realistic) performance.

Vibha Rani's theatre practice embodies a productive tension between nāṭyadharmi and lokadharmi. Her solo performances—she has pioneered what she calls 'room theatre' (ekānt raṅgamanc) under the banner of AVITOKO, the socio-cultural organisation she founded in Mumbai in 2001—collapse the architectural distinction between stage and audience. In Bhāg Rau, the stage directions explicitly invite the audience into the dramatic action: a 'Darśaka' (spectator) character is listed in the dramatis personae and delivers lines from within the audience space. This is lokadharmi staging deployed within a nāṭyadharmi dramaturgy—a Brechtian gesture that, as we argue below, also resonates with the Nāṭyaśāstra's own concept of sāmānyabhinaya (common/general acting) as a bridge between performer and spectator.

Using Bharata's pañcasandhi schema, the structure of Bhāg Rau reads as follows: the mukha (opening) establishes Mangtū as literate beggar in the train sequence; the pratimukha (development) introduces the journalist duo whose exploitative interest in Mangtū complicates his aspiration; the garbha (womb/complication) is the revelation of Kabitā's gang-rape by her brother and associates; the vimarśa (crisis) is Mangtū's confrontation with the newspaper reporter, police violence on Gaṇpat, and Mangtū's suicidal despair; the nirvahaṇa (resolution) arrives not as narrative closure but as collective choral affirmation—the entire cast freezes in a human flower formation as Mangtū sleeps and the voices of all characters merge in the anti-war poem. This is a deliberately 'failed' nirvahaṇa in classical terms: no hero achieves his goal, no social problem is solved. The failure is itself the aesthetic and political statement.

## II.C Western Critical Theories

### *Aristotle's Poetics and Tragedy*

Aristotle's Poetics defines tragedy as 'an imitation of an action that is serious, complete, and of a certain magnitude… through pity and fear effecting the proper purgation of these emotions' (catharsis). The tragic hero suffers a hamartia (fatal flaw or error) and experiences peripeteia (reversal) and anagnorisis (recognition). Bhāg Rau invites but resists Aristotelian framing: Mangtū's pathos evokes both pity and fear, but his 'flaw' is simply his birth (he is illegitimate, abandoned in a drain, later crippled by a bus accident). This is not hamartia in the Aristotelian sense—it is the structural violence of a social system. Vibha Rani thus occupies the tradition of social tragedy that runs from Büchner through Brecht to Dario Fo: tragedy without a tragic hero in the classical sense, tragedy without cathartic release.

### *Brecht's Epic Theatre*

Bertolt Brecht's Verfremdungseffekt (alienation effect, V-Effekt) seeks to prevent the audience from identifying emotionally with characters so that they can maintain critical distance and recognise the social conditions producing suffering. Brecht's techniques include direct address to the audience, placards, songs that interrupt narrative flow, and the Gestus (social gesture that encapsulates class relationships). Vibha Rani's theatre deploys all these: the play within the play, the journalist characters who oscillate between sympathy and exploitation, the Bollywood film-song references that defamiliarise the street-children's suffering by juxtaposing commercial pleasure with material deprivation, and the darśaka (spectator) character who speaks from within the audience. The effect is profoundly Brechtian: the audience is moved (karuṇa) but simultaneously jolted into reflection (a rasa-V-Effekt synthesis).

### *Feminist Theory*

Simone de Beauvoir's insight that 'woman is not born, but made' and Judith Butler's theory of gender as performativity are essential for reading Balchandā. The play performs this very process of 'making': the actress literally performs the construction of femininity through the rituals of birth-song (sohara), wedding (vidāī), the first night, and then the violent unmaking of the female foetus. Butler's concept of 'citational performativity'—that gender is produced

by the repeated citation of gender norms—is literalised in Balchandā's structure: the character cites and re-cites every stage of a woman's life-cycle, exposing these citations as the mechanism of oppression rather than natural sequence. The play's climactic scene—where the actress serially removes garments in an ironic citation of the apsarā metaphor (Rambhā, Urvaśī, Menakā)—employs feminist shock-theatre to force a recognition of women as sexual objects in the cultural imaginary.

### *Postcolonial Theory*

Frantz Fanon, Homi Bhabha, and Gayatri Spivak's postcolonial frameworks illuminate both the situation of Maithili literature vis-à-vis Hindi (a metropolitan/state language colonising the regional) and the situation of diasporic Maithili writers like Bindeshwar Thakur. Bhabha's 'third space' of enunciation—where colonial and colonised cultures meet and hybridise—describes the condition of Maithili writers who inhabit the interstices between Maithili and Hindi (in Vibha Rani's case), or between Maithili and Nepali/global Arabic (in Bindeshwar Thakur's case). Spivak's question 'Can the subaltern speak?' is urgently enacted in Bhāg Rau: Mangtū is repeatedly silenced—by the journalist who cuts his interview short when he says too much, by the police who beat him, by the institutional structures that deny him work. His literacy—his capacity to read newspapers—becomes a tragic irony: he can read the world but cannot write himself into it.

### *Diasporic Studies*

Stuart Hall's theorisation of diasporic identity as 'not a fixed origin to which we can make some final and absolute Return' but a 'production… never complete, always in process' is directly applicable to Bindeshwar Thakur's poetry and prose. Writing from Qatar—the 'marubhūmi' (desert/waste land) of his title Nepālak Nor Marubhūmi Me (In the Desert of Nepal's Tear)—Thakur inhabits a triple diaspora: as a Nepali-side Maithili speaker distanced from the Bihar-India Maithili literary mainstream; as a Gulf migrant labour worker distanced from Nepal; and as a vernacular Maithili poet operating within the global Urdu-Persian ghazal tradition, itself a diasporic form. His ghazals are formally classical (sher-o-shāirī, radif, maqtā) but their emotional content—longing for family, the indignity of migrant work, the exploitation of the poor by the political class—is resolutely contemporary and materialist.

## II.D The Videha Parallel History Framework

The Videha Parallel History Framework, developed by Gajendra Thakur in his role as editor of Videha (ISSN 2229-547X), the first Maithili fortnightly e-journal (launched 2004; predecessor 'Bhālsarik Gāchh' blog 2000), constitutes a revisionist historiography of Maithili literature. Its central claims are:

- The dominant narrative of Maithili literary history has been shaped by institutions—Sahitya Akademi, Maithili Akademi (Patna), Nepal's Prajñā Pratiṣṭhān—that disproportionately represent upper-caste (Maithil Brahmin and Karna Kayastha) interests and aesthetics.
- This has produced a 'canonical' Maithili literature centred on Sanskrit-derived classical forms (padāvalī, kīrtaniyā nāṭak) and overlooked or suppressed the creative output of non-Brahmin communities, women, Dalits, Muslims, and diaspora writers.
- The term 'Videha' deliberately invokes the ancient kingdom of Videha (Janakpur/Mithila region) whose political boundaries were trans-national, as a counter-symbol to narrow regionalisms.
- Parallel literature in Maithili—a tradition the Videha journal has documented and promoted—finds its precedent in the Vedas (the Naraśaṃsī stanzas as parallel literature) and is not a recent invention.
- Gajendra Thakur's Panji Prabandh project (deciphering 11,000 palm-leaf genealogical manuscripts) has revealed around 100 inter-caste marriages historically, demonstrating that caste endogamy in Mithila was always more contested and fluid than the Brahminical narrative admits.

This framework has direct bearing on how we situate Vibha Rani, Bindeshwar Thakur, and Anmol Jha. All three have their primary publication-and-critical reception through the Videha/Shruti Prakashan network, which constitutes the 'parallel' literary-publishing ecosystem against the Akademi-centred mainstream. Vibha Rani's Bhāg Rau and Balchandā were published by Shruti Prakashan and archived on videha.co.in. Bindeshwar Thakur explicitly thanks the Videha network in his preface, crediting Gajendra Thakur and fellow Videha-associated writers Ashish Anachinhāra, Umesh Mandal, and Pankaj Chaudhary for sustained mentorship. Anmol Jha's CCRT research was enabled

by the community of scholars and texts that the Videha platform made accessible.

## II.E Bihani Kathā vs Laghukathā: The Genre Debate

One of the most productive internal debates in contemporary Maithili literary criticism concerns the distinction between bihani kathā (literally 'morning/dawn story'—also rendered as 'seed story' or vihanikathā) and laghukathā (short-short story). This debate has both formal and ideological dimensions.

Laghukathā, as a genre, has its Hindi analogue, has been theorised extensively in Hindi since the 1970s. It is characterised by extreme brevity (typically under 500 words), a single culminating irony or twist, socio-political critique, and a preference for the third-person omniscient perspective. Its closest Western analogue is the flash fiction or prose poem. The Jaina tradition recognised laghukathā as a distinct narrative category alongside lokakathā, nīti-kathā, and dṛṣṭāntakathā.

The Videha school, however, argues that bihani kathā (also spelled vihanikathā) is formally and ontologically distinct from laghukathā: it is not merely 'shorter' but operates on a different phenomenological principle. Where laghukathā resolves into a single punch-line or ironic reversal, bihani kathā is deliberately open, seed-like, germinating in the reader's imagination without closure. The bihani is not a compressed narrative but a narrative seed—it plants an image, a situation, or a fragment of consciousness and allows the reader to grow the full story. Gajendra Thakur's own bihani kathā compositions, as well as those of Bindeshwar Thakur (in the 'Bihani Kathā Khaṇḍa' of Nepālak Nor Marubhūmi Me), exemplify this principle.

The practical significance of this debate for our three writers: Anmol Jha's Samay Sākṣī Ṭhik is explicitly subtitled 'Maithilī Laghukathā-Saṅgraha'—it situates itself in the laghukathā tradition. Bindeshwar Thakur includes both laghukathā and bihani kathā sections in his composite volume, treating them as distinct modes. The Videha school's theorisation of bihani kathā as an indigenous Maithili form (rather than a borrowing from Hindi laghukathā) is

part of the Parallel History project of asserting Maithili's formal distinctiveness and autochthonous literary heritage.

## II.F The Bilingual Writers Debate

The question of bilingualism in Maithili literary culture is complex and politically charged. Maithili has always existed in multilingual contact with Sanskrit, Braj, Hindi, Bengali, Nepali, and now English. But the specific question of writers who produce work in both Maithili and Hindi—or Maithili and Nepali—raises anxieties about language loyalty, market incentives, and cultural authenticity.

The conservative position (associated with several mainstream Maithili scholars and the Sahitya Akademi's Maithili advisory board) holds that bilingual writers inevitably compromise the purity and distinctiveness of Maithili and that their Hindi works attract more institutional recognition (larger audiences, larger advances, national awards), creating a perverse incentive structure that drains talent from Maithili. The progressive position—articulated within the Videha framework—holds that bilingualism is a resource, not a deficit: that writers like Vibha Rani who move between Maithili and Hindi enrich both languages and create potential audiences for Maithili among Hindi readers. Moreover, the Videha position points out that the greatest Maithili poets historically (Vidyapati) also composed in Braj and Sanskrit, and that monolingualism was never the norm for literate Maithilis.

Vibha Rani is the test case par excellence. She writes fiction (Khoh Se Niksait, Maithili) and plays (Bhāg Rau, Balchandā, Maithili) but also Hindi short story collections (Band Kamre kā Koras, Isī Deś ke Isī Śahar Meṃ) and Hindi plays (Pregnant Father, 2020—winner of the Nemichandra Jain Playwriting Award; Dūsrā Ādmī, Bhāraṅgam 2002). She translates from Maithili into Hindi for Sahitya Akademi award-winning authors, creating institutional bridges. Her bilingualism is creative, not merely commercial: her Hindi and Maithili voices are in productive dialogue, often staging the same social problematic (gender violence, caste discrimination, marginalisation) from different cultural angles.

## II.G India–Nepal Maithili Asymmetry

Maithili is spoken by approximately 11 million people in Bihar and Jharkhand (India) and an estimated 3 million in Nepal's Madhesh Province (the Terai region). It is recognised as an official language of Nepal (Schedule 8 of the Interim Constitution, 2007). Despite this formal parity, the cultural and institutional centres of Maithili literary production have historically been in India (Darbhanga, Madhubani, Patna), and Nepali Maithili writers have consistently complained of marginalisation by the Indian literary establishment.

The specific grievances articulated by Nepali Maithili writers and critics include: (1) the Sahitya Akademi's Maithili advisory structure is dominated by Indian Maithilis; (2) Nepal's Prajñā Pratiṣṭhān (the Nepalese counterpart of Sahitya Akademi) has given insufficient attention to contemporary Maithili literature, focusing on Nepali-language productions; (3) Nepali Maithili writers like Bindeshwar Thakur, who write in the Gulf diaspora, occupy a double periphery (peripheral to both Indian Maithili and Nepali institutional structures); (4) the Videha platform has been one of the few spaces where Nepali-side Maithili writers receive equal critical attention—a fact Bindeshwar Thakur himself acknowledges in his preface.

The Videha Parallel History Framework explicitly addresses this asymmetry: it positions itself as a trans-national Maithili project and publishes writers from both the Indian and Nepali sides of the Mithila cultural region without prioritising either. Gajendra Thakur's historical research (the Panji Prabandh project) reveals that the political boundaries between India and Nepal were imposed by British colonialism and the subsequent Sugauli Treaty (1816) and that the Mithila cultural region predates and transcends these borders. This is not merely romantic nationalism but a historically grounded argument for cultural reintegration.

## II.H Navya-Nyāya Epistemology as Critical Method

The Navya-Nyāya school of Indian philosophy, founded by Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya of Mithila in the 13th–14th century CE and continued by Raghunātha Śiromaṇi of Nabadwipa, developed a highly technical analytical language for epistemology and logic. Gaṅgeśa's magnum opus, the

Tattvacintāmaṇi ('Thought-Jewel of Reality'), distinguishes four means of valid knowledge (pramāṇas): perception (pratyakṣa), inference (anumāna), comparison (upamāna), and verbal testimony (śabda). The school's key technical innovations include: the concept of avacchedakatā (limitation/conditionality), which allows for universalisation; the detailed analysis of viṣayatā (objecthood) in cognition; and the theory of pakṣatā (suppositional reasoning) in inference.

Crucially, Gaṅgeśa was himself a Maithili—born and working in Mithila—and Navya-Nyāya remained an active intellectual tradition centred in Mithila and subsequently Bengal until the 18th century. Navya-Nyāya techniques, as Jonardon Ganeri has shown, proved so versatile that they were applied not only in philosophy but in poetics, linguistics, and legal theory. It is therefore not anachronistic but culturally appropriate to apply Navya-Nyāya epistemological categories to the analysis of Maithili literary texts.

Applied to literary criticism, the Navya-Nyāya framework yields the following critical tools. First, the distinction between jñāna (veridical cognition) and ajñāna (non-veridical/false cognition) maps onto the distinction between literary truth-claims and fictional or ideological distortions—allowing us to ask: what kind of knowledge does a text produce, and through which pramāṇa? Second, the concept of avacchedakatā (conditioned limitation) allows us to specify the precise conditions under which a generic classification (e.g., 'this is a bihani kathā') holds, which is directly applicable to the bihani kathā vs laghukathā genre debate. Third, the Navya-Nyāya analysis of vyāpti (pervasion/universal connection)—'wherever there is smoke there is fire'—provides a model for the structural analysis of thematic invariants across a writer's corpus: if every play by Vibha Rani contains the dyad literacy/deprivation, this pervasion is analytically significant. Fourth, pakṣatā (suppositional reasoning) models the interpretive act itself: the reader forms a supposition about a text's meaning and tests it against the textual evidence—a process structurally analogous to Navya-Nyāya inference.

# III. Vibha Rani: Works and Critical Appreciation

## III.A Biographical and Literary Profile

Vibha Rani was born in Madhuban (Madhubani district, Bihar) and is based in Mumbai. She writes in Hindi and Maithili and has published over twenty books across both languages. Her Hindi publications include the short story collections Band Kamre kā Koras (winner, Ghanshyamdas Saraf Sahitya Samman), Isī Deś ke Isī Śahar Meṃ, and Chal Khusrō Ghar Āpne; her Maithili publications include Khoh Se Niksait (stories), Mithilā kī Lokakathāeṃ, Gonū Jhā ke Kisse (folk tales), and the plays Bhāg Rau, Balchandā, and Madad Karu Santoṣī Mātā. She has translated seven books of three Sahitya Akademi award-winning Maithili authors into Hindi. She has received the Katha Award, Mohan Rakesh Samman, Mahesh Sarvottam Sahitya Samman, Nemichandra Jain Playwriting Award (2020), and Lakṣmī-Hari Samman (2022) for her Maithili novel, among more than thirty awards. She is the founder of AVITOKO (2001), a socio-cultural organisation that works with marginalised communities through theatre and art, including jail inmates' children.

As a performer, Rani is a pioneer of solo theatre (ekānt raṅgamanc) and has acted in Hindi films (Laal Kaptaan, Shamshera) and web series (Maharani). She documents and performs the folk traditions of Mithila—gālī gīt (teasing songs), Vidyapati in various rāgas—and practises a form of cultural stewardship that her theatrical work is inseparable from.

## III.B Bhāg Rau (Run Away): Close Reading

### *Synopsis and Structure*

Bhāg Rau (published Shruti Prakashan, Delhi, 2009; ISBN 978-93-80538-01-3) is a full-length Maithili play in two acts. The dramatis personae includes thirty-two named characters and a chorus of spectators, covering a cross-section of urban marginality: Mangtū (the disabled, literate beggar-protagonist), three child beggars (Chanrā, Gobarā, Jhunmā), Gaṇpat (the banana vendor), Rājū (Gaṇpat's exploitative son), three male thugs, two transgender characters (hijṛā), two journalists (male/female), two police constables, students, passengers, and a shadowy figure named Tāmbe (the data-hungry bureaucrat).

The play is staged primarily at a bus-stand/train-station and on the streets of an unnamed North Indian city.

Act I establishes the social landscape through three interconnected narrative strands: the child beggars' daily income calculation and police extortion (Scene 1–2); the journalist duo's encounter with Mangtū as a 'story' (Scene 2); and the assault on Gaṇpat's daughter by her own brother and his associates (Scene 2). Act II deepens the exploration of Mangtū's interiority—his encounters with the hijṛā community, a wealthy donor, Tāmbe (the bureaucrat who uses Mangtū's knowledge and gives him no credit), and finally the young street vendor Jhunmā—culminating in the nightmare sequence where Mangtū's arms and legs are restored in a dream only for a bomb blast (Scene 3) to explode the vision. The play ends with all characters joining a collective anti-war/anti-fatalist choral statement.

### *Thematic Analysis*

The play's central theme is the paradox of visible invisibility: Mangtū is hyper-visible as a disabled beggar (people see his disability immediately) yet invisible as a person (no one sees his literacy, his inner life, his capacity for labour). This paradox is literalised through the journalists: they see him as a 'story' (a spectacle of disability + literacy = curiosity) rather than as a subject. Their interview sequence—notepad in hand, calculating an award from the story's publication—is a merciless exposure of the 'compassion industry' in journalism.

The play also stages the multiple forms of exploitation that converge on the urban poor: police extortion ('dādā kā hiṣṣā, dādā kā'), institutional neglect (no welfare reaches Mangtū), family betrayal (Rājū's violence against his sister Kabitā), and the appropriation of knowledge (Tāmbe extracts data from Mangtū's encyclopaedic newspaper-knowledge without credit or payment). Each form of exploitation is represented by a specific character or scene, creating a systemic rather than individual analysis.

The hijṛā (transgender) characters are given extended stage time and political voice: they articulate with bitter clarity their exclusion from both 'man' and 'woman' categories, their economic marginalisation (one rupee per shop per

week), and their experience of dignity-denial in formal labour markets. Their presence in the play is not merely for local colour but constitutes a second axis of exclusion parallel to Mangtū's disability: both are bodies that the mainstream refuses to recognise as productive workers.

### *Formal and Linguistic Analysis*

The play's language is one of its most distinctive achievements. Rani writes in a Maithili that is determinedly contemporary and plurilingual: film-song references ('Koi mil gayā', 'Aatī kyā Khaṇḍālā'), street Hindi ('sāla', 'bhosḍī ke'), Bollywood actor names as sarcastic appellatives ('Govindā', 'Hrithik Roshan'), and passages of lyrical literary Maithili in the stage directions and choral poems. This multilingual texture is not 'code-switching' in a deficit sense but a sophisticated representation of the actual linguistic life of the urban poor in contemporary India—a life in which Bhojpuri, Maithili, Hindi, and filmi language coexist and interpenetrate.

The songs—sohara, kajari, barsāt ke gīt—embedded in the play's second act are not mere decorative folk-lore insertions. They function as Brechtian interruptions that comment ironically on the dramatic action: the monsoon song 'Sakhī he āyal rāt andhiārī' (Oh friend, dark night has come) plays as Mangtū speaks of rain as life-force, while the stage reality is one of flooding, displacement, and economic catastrophe for street-dwellers. The song and the social reality produce a polyphonic irony that neither cancels the other.

Applying Navya-Nyāya's concept of vyāpti (pervasion), we can identify a structural invariant across the play: wherever there is literacy in Bhāg Rau, there is deprivation. The newspaper is Mangtū's primary access to the world—yet it is also the instrument through which he reads about Kabitā's rape, about bomb blasts, about poverty statistics. The newspaper is both epistemic enabler and epistemic wound: it gives him knowledge that cannot help him and knowledge that hurts him. This pervasion—literacy as double-edged—is the play's central Navya-Nyāya 'inference point': it allows the reader/audience to infer the systemic nature of exclusion from any individual instance.

## III.C Balchandā: A Feminist Dramaturgy

### *Structure and Performance*

Balchandā (a mono-drama; also published in Bhāg Rau āā Balchandā, 2009, Shruti Prakashan) is performed by a single actress who embodies multiple roles: the unborn female child, the mother, the mother-in-law, the father, the announcer, the journalist, the bride. The play covers approximately ninety minutes of playing time and requires exceptional physical and vocal range from its performer. It was presented at the college annual day as a nāṭak within the fiction of the play itself, creating a meta-theatrical frame.

The play opens with a cosmological statement of female principle—'Ham dhariṇī, ham dharitrī / Sītā ham, ham Sāvitrī'—before descending through the specific social mechanisms of female foeticide: the dowry calculation, the mother-in-law's preference for male children, the husband's acquiescence to family pressure, the journalist's dispassionate documentation, and the foetus's dream-voice calling to be born. The play's theatrical climax—the sequential amputation of the actress's limbs in mime as the foetus is aborted piece by piece—is among the most viscerally powerful theatrical moments in contemporary Indian drama.

### *Feminist Critical Reading*

Read through Judith Butler's lens of gender performativity, Balchandā is literally a performance of the performance of femininity. The actress 'cites' every cultural norm governing Indian womanhood—sohara (birth songs), pāzeb (anklets), kājal (kohl), ghūṃghaṭ (veil), sindūra (vermilion), solah śṛṅgāra (sixteen ornaments)—and then reveals each citation as a link in a chain of exploitation rather than an expression of cultural beauty. The play's Maithili songs—Vidyapati bhajana, the traditional bihāh gīt (wedding song)—are mobilised to expose rather than celebrate tradition: they are sung as the actress enacts increasingly violent marital subjugation.

The figure of the father (Bāujī) who supports his daughter's desire for engineering education is a counter-symbol: a rural, less-educated man who is more progressive than his urban-educated son-in-law. This reversal—the 'backward' rural father as the true modernist—disrupts the developmental

narrative that locates women's emancipation in urban education and professionalism. It is also a rare positive male character in feminist Indian drama, avoiding the simplification of patriarchy as individual male villainy rather than systemic cultural inheritance.

### *Nāṭyaśāstra Reading: Abhinaya and the Female Body*

The Nāṭyaśāstra's theory of sāttvika abhinaya (psychological/involuntary acting) describes the physical manifestations of inner emotion: trembling (kampa), horripilation (romāñca), tears (aśru), paralysis (stambha). Balchandā demands all of these from its performer, but within a consciously meta-theatrical frame: the actress must produce sāttvika abhinaya while simultaneously deploying nāṭyadharmi (theatrical/stylised) gesture. The final mime of amputation is in this sense pure nāṭyadharmi—no blood, no realistic staging—yet it produces profound sāttvika response in the audience. This synthesis of stylised form and visceral content is the play's highest formal achievement and aligns it with the best traditions of Indian physical theatre (Kutiyattam, Bharatanāṭyam) while serving a radically contemporary political purpose.

# IV. Bindeshwar Thakur: Works and Critical Appreciation

## IV.A Biographical and Literary Profile

Bindeshwar Thakur is a Nepali-side Maithili writer working as a migrant labourer in Qatar (Gulf diaspora). His volume Nepālak Nor Marubhūmi Me (In the Desert of Nepal's Tear, 2014; ISBN 978-93-80538-99-0; Shruti Prakashan, Delhi; designed by Priti Thakur; distributed by Pallavi Distributors, Supaul) is a composite literary work containing ghazal, sher-o-shāirī, laghukathā, bihani kathā, and kavitā sections. The title is a triple allusion: to the Maithili (and Urdu) tradition of nora (tear) as the dominant trope of love-poetry and ghazal; to the physical marubhūmi (desert) of Qatar; and to the political sense of 'desert'—wasteland, abandonment—in which Nepali migrant workers are stranded by economic inequality.

In his preface (āmukh), Thakur acknowledges three institutional supports: the International Nepali Literary Society (Qatar Chapter), the 'Nabodit Sāhityika Mobile Library', and most importantly the Videha Group and its editor Gajendra Thakur, without whose sustained guidance and encouragement, he states, these scattered compositions would never have been collected and published. He also thanks fellow Videha-associated writers Ashish Anachinhāra, Umesh Mandal, Pankaj Chaudhary, and the poets Amit and Śāntilakṣmī Dīdī.

## IV.B The Ghazal Section: Form, Prosody, and Thematic Content

The ghazal is a Persian-Urdu lyric form characterised by the matla (opening couplet, both lines of which end in the radif—refrain—and rhyme/qāfiyā), the body sher (individual couplets, each thematically complete), and the maqtā (closing couplet, in which the poet names himself). The Maithili ghazal tradition has its roots in the Persian-Urdu influence mediated through Bihari Urdu literary culture (Darbhanga, Muzaffarpur). Thakur's ghazals follow the traditional sher-o-shāirī conventions and are composed in what he calls 'saral bāṇīk bakhar' (simple prosodic metre), with the syllable-count indicated after each ghazal (a practice derived from Urdu prosody).

The thematic content of Thakur's ghazals oscillates between three registers: devotional (bhakti ghazal—addressed to the goddess Bhavānī), romantic (śṛṅgāra ghazal—the beloved as moon, the poet as cakora bird), and socio-political (the politician as blood-sucker, unemployment, the exploitation of migrant labour). The seasonal ghazals—holikā (Holi), māghe saṃkrāiti (Makar Sankranti)—express the anguish of the migrant who celebrates Bihari/Maithili festivals vicariously, 'baurāit chī ekhanū katārme' (wandering even now in Qatar). This temporal displacement—festival time at home, work-time in the desert—is the affective core of the volume.

In formal terms, Thakur's ghazals demonstrate a comfortable command of the genre's conventions while adapting them to Maithili phonology. The word 'norana' (tear) recurs as both radif and thematic anchor across multiple ghazals: it is simultaneously the personal tear of separation-longing, the political tear of exploitation, and the literary tear of the ghazal tradition itself (ghazal is etymologically related to Arabic words for grief and lamentation). The systematic repetition of nora across the volume creates an intertextual vyāpti (pervasion) that binds the collection thematically.

The bhakti ghazals are formally innovative: they maintain the ghazal's structural requirements but address the goddess rather than the beloved, adapting the erotic-devotional ambiguity of the Vidyapati tradition (where the beloved and the deity are interchangeable) to the ghazal form. Lines such as 'Ahīṃ chī hamar bhavānī maiyā ham ahāṃk mānai chī' (You alone are my Bhavānī, my mother—I worship you) directly echo Vidyapati's padāvalī devotional idiom within a Persian-Urdu formal structure—a productive intercultural synthesis.

## IV.C Sher-o-Shāirī Section

The sher-o-shāirī section contains individual sher (Urdu couplets) in Maithili, without the full ghazal structure. These couplets are more politically unguarded than the ghazals: they attack political corruption directly ('Hamra nāma becik' khāebalā cor chai / Hak adhikār lā lajāebālā cor chai'—Those who sell our names and eat are thieves; those who are shameless about our rights are thieves), the exploitation of widows, and the systemic production of poverty.

The sher-o-shāirī also includes muktā (independent couplets) addressing themes of love-betrayal and the migrant condition.

The Navya-Nyāya concept of pakṣatā (suppositional/inferential reasoning) is useful here: each sher presents a pakṣa (thesis) and sādhya (what is to be proved) in compressed couplet form. For instance: 'Petabhair khāeb kaṭhin chai etaū / Rojagārī pāeb kaṭhin chai etaū / Netā lokini bhale je kichu bājil āi / Berojagārī bhagāeb kaṭhin chai etaū' (Eating one's fill is difficult here / Finding employment is difficult here / Let the politicians say what they will / Banishing unemployment is difficult here)—the pakṣa is the politician's claim, the sādhya is the refutation, and the vyāpti is 'wherever there are politicians, there are empty promises about unemployment.'

## IV.D Laghukathā and Bihani Kathā

The prose sections of Nepālak Nor Marubhūmi Me include both laghukathā and bihani kathā. The laghukathā conform to the genre's characteristic ironic closure: a brief narrative scene building to a single revelatory moment that overturns the initial premise or exposes a social contradiction. The bihani kathā, by contrast, are more open and imagistic: they present a fragment of experience—a migrant worker's memory of his daughter, a village scene observed from the Gulf—without narrative resolution, allowing the reader to complete the emotional arc.

The presence of both genres in a single volume is itself significant. It suggests that Thakur—like many writers in the Videha circle—understands the generic distinction as productive rather than mutually exclusive: the laghukathā's ironic closure is appropriate for socio-political critique, while the bihani kathā's openness is appropriate for lyrical evocation of absence and longing. The generic choice enacts different epistemological stances: the laghukathā presumes knowledge (it reveals what was hidden); the bihani kathā confesses ignorance (it leaves the reader in the condition of the writer, not knowing how to complete the story of separation and return).

In Navya-Nyāya terms: the laghukathā produces jñāna (veridical cognition) through anumāna (inference)—the reader infers the full social picture from the

particular instance. The bihani kathā produces what we might call a-niścaya (doubt, suspended cognition)—the Navya-Nyāya category of inconclusiveness that is not mere ignorance but a refined epistemological state of knowing-that-one-does-not-know. The bihani is an aestheticised a-niścaya.

## IV.E The India–Nepal Asymmetry: Thakur's Position

Bindeshwar Thakur's case crystallises the structural asymmetry between Indian and Nepali Maithili literary culture. As a Nepali citizen writing in Maithili, working in Qatar, and published by an Indian publishing house (Shruti Prakashan, Delhi) through an India-based e-journal (Videha), he occupies multiple peripheries simultaneously. The Nepali literary establishment has given him minimal attention (the Nepal Prajñā Pratiṣṭhān's Maithili focus has historically been weak). The Indian literary establishment treats Nepali Maithili writers as secondary to Bihar-based Maithili writers. The Gulf diasporic context produces a third layer of cultural displacement.

The Videha platform's explicit commitment to trans-national Maithili culture—reflected in Gajendra Thakur's own historical research on the ancient Videha kingdom's trans-border geography—has made it the primary institutional home for writers like Bindeshwar Thakur. His preface's extensive acknowledgment of the Videha community is not merely personal gratitude but a political statement: the Videha network provides the institutional legitimacy that both national literary establishments (Indian and Nepali) deny him.

Applying postcolonial theory: Thakur's situation exemplifies what Bhabha calls the 'colonial mimicry' of the dominated subject who must adopt the metropolitan's cultural forms to be heard. He writes in the Urdu-Persian ghazal—a form that carries prestige in both Hindi-Urdu and Maithili literary cultures—to gain legitimacy for content (migrant labour, Nepali rural poverty, Gulf exploitation) that is otherwise invisible to both establishments. His cultural hybridity is not a free choice but a strategic negotiation.

# V. Anmol Jha: Works and Critical Appreciation

## V.A Biographical and Literary Profile

Dr Anmol Jha is a Maithili writer, critic, and researcher currently based in Kolkata. He holds a senior research fellowship from the Centre for Cultural Resources and Training (CCRT), Ministry of Culture, Government of India (File No. CCRT/SF-3/320/2022; Enrollment No. SF20216261; Batch Year 2020–2021), which funded a two-year (2023–2025) research project on Samakālīn Maithilī Bāl Sāhityak Vivechanātmak Adhyayan (A Critical Study of Contemporary Maithili Children's Literature). The resulting 745-page report, submitted September 2025, is among the most comprehensive critical surveys of Maithili children's literature ever produced. His creative works include Samay Sākṣī Ṭhik (a laghukathā collection, Shruti Prakashan; ISBN 978-93-80538-47-1) and Ee Je Samay Achhi (another Maithili collection archived on videha.co.in).

## V.B Samay Sākṣī Ṭhik: Laghukathā as Social Witness

The title Samay Sākṣī Ṭhik (roughly: 'Time Itself Is the Witness' or 'Right that Time is Witness') announces both the genre (laghukathā as condensed testimony) and the epistemology (time as the ultimate pramāṇa—means of valid knowledge). The collection belongs to the tradition of socio-political laghukathā in the Hindi-Maithili sphere, depicting the struggles of ordinary people against systemic injustice: political corruption, gender discrimination, poverty, rural-urban migration.

The collection is dedicated 'lal ej, āvag, jīvan ḍugabāk anek chhoṭ-choṭ peṭhak bhed-bhāk jī ṭhik sī ET kālej kar kaloīk lek hamr chhī' (to the enduring memory of small and large sorrows that constitute a life worth living)—a dedication that frames the laghukathā's brevity as a form adequate to the fragmentary experience of social life. Each story is a shard of social testimony rather than a complete narrative arc, consistent with the genre's epistemology of the flash-observation.

The formal characteristics of Jha's laghukathā: typical length of 200–400 words; third-person omniscient narrator; single scene or moment; ironic or paradoxical closure; preference for dialogic over descriptive writing; minimal character psychology (characters are representative social types rather than individuals). These characteristics conform to the Hindi laghukathā tradition as theorised by Balram and other Hindi laghukathā critics.

Using the Navya-Nyāya framework: each laghukathā in the collection can be analysed as a tarka (argument) consisting of a pakṣa (the apparent social reality), a sādhya (the hidden social contradiction), and a hetu (the logical connector between the two). The genre's characteristic 'twist ending' is a formal anagnorisis in Aristotelian terms—a recognition—but it functions differently from tragic recognition: it does not produce catharsis but anaesthetic shock, a sudden, uncomfortable clarity that motivates reflection rather than emotional release.

## V.C CCRT Research Report: Maithili Children's Literature

Anmol Jha's CCRT research report represents a landmark contribution to Maithili literary scholarship. Its eleven chapters cover the following topics: the developmental history of Maithili children's literature (Chapter 1: Pātham Adhyāya); contemporary Maithili children's journals and magazines (Chapter 2); Maithili children's songs and riddles (Chapter 3: 150+ pages); Sahitya Akademi-awarded Maithili children's books (Chapter 4: 155 pages); contemporary Maithili children's fiction (Chapter 5); contemporary Maithili children's poetry (Chapter 6); contemporary Maithili children's ghazal (Chapter 7); contemporary Maithili children's novel (Chapter 8); Maithili children's drama and one-act plays (Chapter 9); translation in 21st-century Maithili children's literature (Chapter 10); and other genres (Chapter 11).

The research is notable for several reasons: it surveys primary sources across both Indian and Nepali Maithili publishing; it attends to non-canonical genres (children's ghazal, children's riddles) that mainstream Maithili criticism has ignored; it documents the institutional landscape of Maithili children's publishing (journals, school textbook policies, the question of Maithili-medium primary education in Bihar—where Maithili children are denied mother-tongue education in state schools); and it makes explicit the connection between

literary production for children and the broader linguistic rights of the Maithili-speaking community.

The report's preface (bhūmikā) articulates a philosophy of children's literature grounded in the idea that children's imaginative range is conditioned by the literary environment provided to them. It cites Śankara Miśra's child prodigy in Mithila (who memorised the Pañcatantra at age five) as evidence of the intellectual tradition of Mithilā in children's education, and argues that the decline of Maithili children's literature is inseparable from the marginalisation of Maithili as a medium of primary education.

From the Videha Parallel History perspective, Jha's research participates in the broader project of documenting and rehabilitating the excluded literature of the Maithili tradition. Children's literature has been systematically undervalued by the literary establishment (the Sahitya Akademi has no children's literature award in Maithili comparable to other languages), and Jha's comprehensive survey makes this gap visible and measurable.

## V.D The Bilingual Critic: Jha's Critical Methodology

Anmol Jha's critical practice is itself bilingual and methodologically pluralist: his CCRT report is written in Hindi/Maithili with extensive use of both languages' critical vocabularies. He draws on Indian aesthetic categories (rasa, alamkāra, dhvani) as well as Western genre theory (the novel, the short story, translation studies) without privileging either framework. This methodological bilingualism enacts the 'bilingual writer' position in practice: neither language's critical tradition is adequate alone, and the most productive criticism moves between them.

The report's discussion of Maithili children's song (bāl gīt) and riddle (paheli) applies the Nāṭyaśāstra's concepts of sukumāra (delicate/tender aesthetic) and audārikā (robust/popular aesthetic) to distinguish between literary children's poetry and folk children's song—a sophisticated application of classical Indian poetics to a genre the tradition did not explicitly theorise. This is precisely the kind of creative theoretical extension that the Navya-Nyāya spirit of analytical rigour and definitional precision encourages.

# VI. Comparative Analysis and Synthesis

## VI.A Common Themes and Concerns

Despite their different genres, positions, and stylistic registers, Vibha Rani, Bindeshwar Thakur, and Anmol Jha share a cluster of thematic concerns that constitutes the distinctive voice of Videha-aligned contemporary Maithili literature.

First, all three writers share a preoccupation with the condition of the economically and socially marginalised: Rani's street children and disabled beggars; Thakur's Gulf migrant workers; Jha's documentation of the pedagogic deprivation of Maithili-speaking children denied education in their mother tongue. This is not mere social realism but an ethical positioning: the writer as sākṣī (witness), the text as pramāṇa (evidence) in the Navya-Nyāya sense—testimony that constitutes valid knowledge about conditions that institutional structures render invisible.

Second, all three engage with gender in ways that challenge both mainstream Maithili conservatism and metropolitan feminist abstraction. Rani's Balchandā situates the female body at the intersection of cultural tradition and structural violence. Thakur's ghazals contain both romantic-devotional idealisation of the feminine (the beloved-as-goddess trope) and politically engaged critique of widow exploitation and gender discrimination. Jha's children's literature survey reveals that Maithili children's literature has historically underrepresented girl protagonists and female authors—a gap his research makes visible and actionable.

Third, all three writers are embedded in the Maithili diasporic condition: Rani writes from Mumbai about Bihar; Thakur writes from Qatar about Nepal/Mithila; Jha writes from Kolkata about the Maithili literary world. None writes from within the traditional geographic and institutional centres of Maithili literary production (Darbhanga, Madhubani, Patna). This shared peripherality is not accidental but constitutive: the Videha Parallel History Framework is itself a project of the Maithili diaspora, founded by a Delhi-based editor, and its most productive contributors are those who write Maithili from outside the Brahminical heartland's institutional structures.

## VI.B Genre and Form as Political Practice

The generic choices made by our three writers are themselves politically significant in the context of the Maithili literary field.

Vibha Rani's choice of drama—specifically a drama in colloquial, plurilingual Maithili staged for mass audiences—is a political choice within a literary field that has historically privileged Sanskrit-influenced literary Maithili in poetry. By making theatre the primary vehicle of her Maithili work, she connects to the oldest Maithili literary tradition (the kīrtaniyā nāṭak of the medieval period; the Sanskrit-Prakrit dramas of the Mall dynasty era in Nepal) while simultaneously radically democratising the form: a play about beggars and street children in the idiom of the street.

Bindeshwar Thakur's choice of the ghazal—an Urdu-Persian import that is nonetheless deeply naturalised in Maithili culture through the Bihar Urdu literary tradition—makes a claim for Maithili's cosmopolitan openness. Against narratives of Maithili as 'pure' Sanskrit-derived language (a Brahminical exclusivist claim), Thakur's ghazals enact the historical openness of Maithili to Persian-Arabic influence. His composite volume—mixing ghazal, sher-o-shāirī, laghukathā, bihani kathā, and kavitā—is itself a formal statement against genre purity: the migrant condition cannot be captured in a single form.

Anmol Jha's choice of the laghukathā as his primary creative form and of children's literature as his primary research subject makes a different kind of political claim: the claim that the most important Maithili literature is that which reaches the widest audience with the greatest social impact. The laghukathā's democratic legibility (no specialised aesthetic education required to enjoy it) and children's literature's targeting of the youngest and most formative readers are both expressions of a literary populism that the Videha framework has championed against the elitist aestheticism of the mainstream academy.

### VI.C Navya-Nyāya as Unifying Critical Framework

Applying Navya-Nyāya epistemological categories comparatively, we can identify a shared epistemic structure across the three writers' works. All three produce texts that function as pramāṇas—means of valid knowledge—about conditions that are otherwise suppressed or distorted by dominant ideological structures. Rani's plays produce pratyakṣa-like immediacy (the equivalent of direct perception) through theatrical embodiment; Thakur's ghazals produce anumāna-like inference (the personal becomes universal through the vyāpti of the refrain); and Jha's research report produces śabda-pramāṇa (testimony-as-evidence) through its systematic documentation of primary sources.

The Navya-Nyāya concept of avacchedakatā (conditioned limitation) is also useful comparatively: each writer's work is conditioned by specific limiting conditions (upādhi) that must be acknowledged in any critical evaluation. For Rani: the conditioning of her work by her bilingual Hindi/Maithili practice (some of her Maithili dramatic vocabulary is influenced by Hindi theatrical conventions). For Thakur: the conditioning of his Maithili by Nepali linguistic influence and Gulf diasporic experience (his Maithili is not identical to standard Bihar Maithili). For Jha: the conditioning of his children's literature survey by the CCRT institutional framework, which brings both resources and constraints. None of these limiting conditions invalidates the work; the Navya-Nyāya framework insists that all knowledge is conditioned knowledge, and the task is to specify the conditions rather than pretend to an unconditioned view.

## VII. Conclusion

The three writers studied in this monograph—Vibha Rani, Bindeshwar Thakur, and Anmol Jha—collectively represent a vital current in contemporary Maithili literature: the Videha-aligned parallel literary movement that has created, since the year 2000, an alternative institutional infrastructure for Maithili literary production, publication, and critical reception outside the dominant Akademi-centred establishment.

Vibha Rani's Maithili plays Bhāg Rau and Balchandā represent the highest achievement of contemporary Maithili drama. They synthesise the Nāṭyaśāstra's rasa theory with Brechtian epic theatre, apply both feminist theory and Navya-Nyāya epistemology to the theatrical representation of social

marginality, and deploy a plurilingual Maithili that is both culturally specific and politically urgent. Their publication by Shruti Prakashan and archiving on videha.co.in ensures their continued accessibility to a global Maithili readership.

Bindeshwar Thakur's Nepālak Nor Marubhūmi Me is a landmark in the literature of the Maithili diaspora and specifically in the emerging genre of Gulf migrant labour literature. By adapting the classical ghazal form to migrant experience, he creates a bridge between the high literary tradition (Urdu-Persian ghazal, Vidyapati padāvalī) and the lived reality of contemporary Mithila's economic crisis. His position as a Nepali-side Maithili writer makes his recognition by the Videha network particularly significant in the context of the India–Nepal Maithili asymmetry.

Anmol Jha's creative laghukathā collection and his monumental CCRT research report together constitute both a creative and a scholarly contribution to Maithili letters. The research report is especially significant: it is likely the most comprehensive survey of Maithili children's literature ever attempted, and it both documents and implicitly advocates for the linguistic rights of Maithili-speaking children in Bihar's educational system.

The Videha Parallel History Framework that contextualises all three writers' work challenges us to read Maithili literature not as a monolithic tradition centred on Sanskrit-Brahmin cultural dominance but as a contested, plural, trans-national, and trans-caste tradition that encompasses the Gulf, the Mumbai suburbs, the Kolkata research libraries, and the streets and train stations of Bihar and Mithila. The application of Navya-Nyāya epistemology—the intellectual tradition of Gaṅgeśa's own Mithila—to contemporary Maithili literary criticism is a reminder that the analytical resources for such a pluralist literary history were always already present within the tradition itself, waiting to be rediscovered and redeployed.

As Bhāg Rau's choral finale puts it: 'Khasab, laḍab, marab / Mudā fer ṭhāḍh bhai uṭhab / Sāṭhi hajār sagar-putrak bhāṃti' (We shall fall, we shall fight, we shall die / But again we shall rise and stand / Like the sixty thousand sons of Sagar). The literature of contemporary Mithila rises and falls and rises again—not

despite its institutional marginalisation, but with it as its subject, its wound, and its most powerful creative resource.

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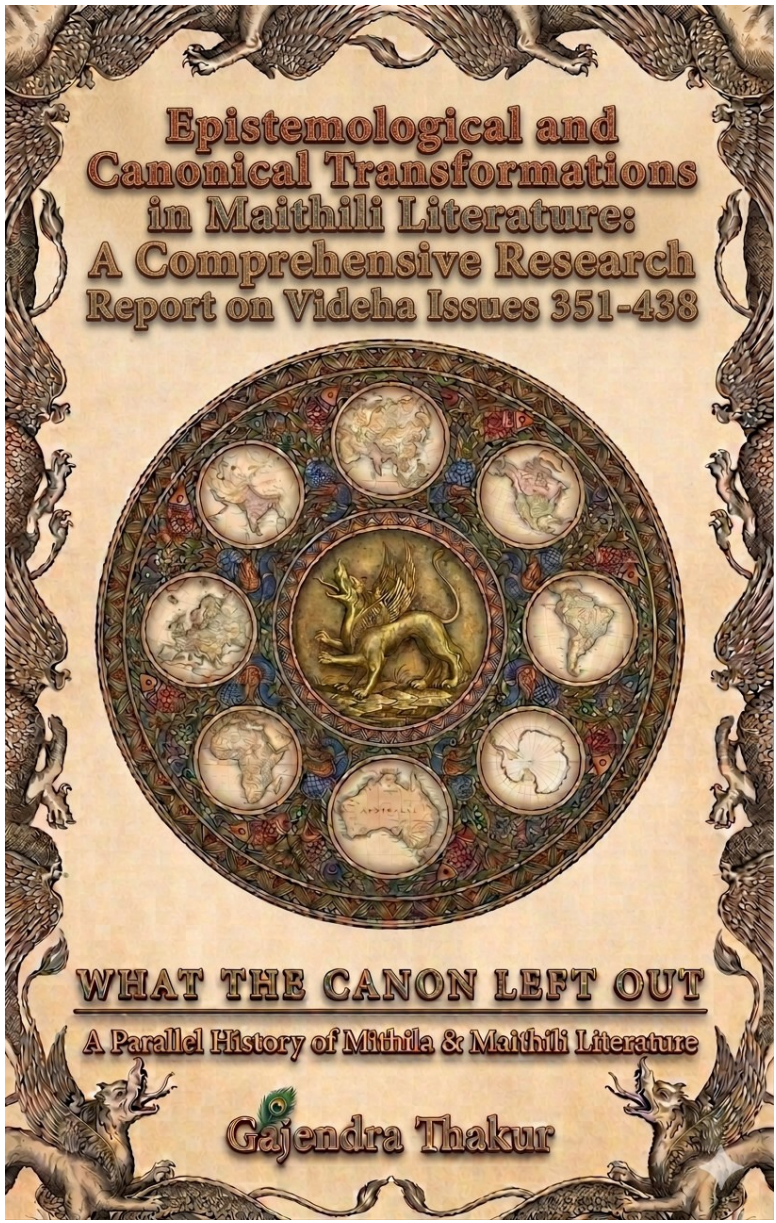
**LESSON 093 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**




## VIDEHA ISSUES 351-438

**Epistemological and Canonical Transformations in Maithili Literature: A Comprehensive Research Report on Videha Issues 351-438**

The evolution of Maithili literature in the early twenty-first century is marked by a profound digital and philosophical shift, centered largely on the interventions of the Videha e-journal. This report provides an exhaustive analysis of Videha issues 351 through 438, drawing exclusively from the primary digital archives of the movement. By utilizing a multidimensional critical framework—integrating the rigorous Navya-Nyāya epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya, the Videha Parallel History Framework, and a synthesis of Indian and Western literary theories—this research elucidates how the Maithili literary landscape has been democratized and intellectually revitalized. The period covered, extending from October 2022 to May 2026, represents a critical phase in the journal's history, characterized by the institutionalization of the "Parallel Tradition" as a counter-canonical force that challenges the established hierarchies of the Sahitya Akademi and other state-sponsored organizations.

**Theoretical Frameworks and Methodological Interventions**

The analysis of the Videha corpus requires a departure from conventional, often caste-blind, literary criticism. The following frameworks provide the necessary rigor for understanding the movement's impact on Maithili identity and intellectual history.

**The Navya-Nyāya Epistemological Technique**

The Maithili literary tradition is unique in its historical proximity to the Navya-Nyāya school of logic, founded by Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya in Mithila during the thirteenth century. The Videha movement reclaims this heritage, not merely as an archival curiosity, but as an active methodology for literary interpretation. In this report, the works in issues 351-438 are evaluated as systems of valid cognition (*pramāṇa*). According to the *Tattvacintāmaṇi*, knowledge is produced through four primary channels: *pratyakṣa* (direct perception), *anumāna* (inference), *upamāna* (comparison), and *śabda* (verbal testimony).

When applied to literature, *pratyakṣa* functions as the foundation of social realism. The writer who precisely observes the particular (*viśeṣa*) social conditions of Mithila—such as rural displacement or gendered health crises—produces a qualified cognition (*viśiṣṭajñāna*) that reveals the universal (*sāmānya*) truth of the human condition. *Anumāna* allows for the inference of social structures from narrative evidence, where a specific literary choice acts as a *hetu* (mark) leading to a valid *sādhya* (conclusion) about societal reality. The concept of *vyāpti* (invariable concomitance) is utilized to establish the reliability of a writer's social critique. Furthermore, the technical apparatus of

*avacchedakatva* (delimitation) is employed to define the boundaries of subaltern and feminist discourse, ensuring that these labels are applied with logical precision.

**The Videha Parallel History Framework**

The Videha Parallel History Framework serves as a counter-narrative to the "mainstream" history of Maithili literature, which the movement argues has been curated to promote an upper-caste, predominantly Maithil Brahmin, canon. This framework identifies nine distinct layers of historical suppression, including the Buddhist *Charyapada* foundations and the contributions of the Nepal-side Maithili community. Key to this framework is the "Thesis of the Two Vidyapatis," which distinguishes the famous Padavali poet from the Sanskrit scholar of the same name, and the "Suppressed Gangesh" thesis, which uses the *Dooshan Panji* (genealogical records) to reveal the inter-caste, subaltern origins of the great logician Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya. By centering voices that are "ignored and non-represented," the framework redefines the Maithili canon as a democratic and inclusive project.

**Synthesis of Indian and Western Criticism**

In addition to indigenous logic and historical frameworks, the research incorporates classical Indian aesthetics and modern Western theory. The *Rasa-Dhvani* theory (Anandavardhana and Abhinavagupta) and the *Vakrokti* theory (Kuntaka) provide the tools for analyzing the aesthetic and suggestive power of Maithili poetry and prose. Simultaneously, Western theories such as New Criticism, Postcolonialism (Bhabha, Spivak), Subaltern Studies (Guha), and Feminist Criticism (Cixous, Butler) allow for a global contextualization of the Maithili experience.

**Thematic Chronology of Videha Issues 351-438**

The issues under review demonstrate a disciplined adherence to a fortnightly publication cycle that integrates seasonal motifs, religious festivals, and socio-political themes. The following table provides a structural overview of the publication calendar and the specific thematic focuses of each issue.

| Issue Number | Publication Date | Primary Thematic Focus and Contextual Significance |
|---|---|---|

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 351–352 | Oct 01–15, 2022 | Shardiya (Dasain) Literature: Integration of ritual aesthetics with subaltern social observation. |
| 353–354 | Nov 01–15, 2022 | Diwali, Chhath, and Sam-Chakeva: Exploration of communal bonding and folk traditions. |
| 355–356 | Dec 01–15, 2022 | General Literature: A showcase of the broader "Nit Naval" (Always New) movement. |
| 357 | Jan 01, 2023 | New Year 2023 Special: Focus on the digital future and linguistic revitalization. |
| 360 | Feb 15, 2023 | Galpi (Storytellers): A critical examination of the narrative techniques in modern Maithili fiction. |
| 362 | Mar 15, 2023 | Mithila Chitrakala (Art): Analyzing the transition of folk art into digital and political spaces. |
| 363 | Apr 01, 2023 | Nabavarsha (Maithili New Year): Reclaiming the cultural calendar and regional identity. |
| 365 | May 01, 2023 | Lok-Gatha (Folk Ballads): Re-interpreting oral traditions like Lorika as literary assets. |
| 368 | Jun 15, 2023 | Maithili Ghazal Special: Focusing on the Anchinhar Aakhar movement’s formal restoration. |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 371 | Sep 01, 2023 | Maithili Nibandh (Essays): Intellectual discourse on organic farming and rural cooperatives. |
| 391 | Jun 01, 2024 | Baalkatha (Children's Stories): Innovating in picture-story formats for the next generation. |
| 400 | Aug 15, 2024 | International Maithili Council: Strategic discussions on global linguistic recognition. |
| 427–428 | Dec 01–15, 2025 | General Literature: Synthesis of contemporary prose and poetry across the Terai and Bihar. |
| 438 | May 15, 2026 | Rangmanch (Theatre): Analyzing the Videha Maithili Parallel Theatre Movement. |

**Alphabetical Catalog of Authors and Works (Issues 351-438)**

The following compendium lists the authors and their significant contributions identified within the Videha archive for the specified period. Each entry includes a brief critical appreciation based on the integrated theoretical frameworks described above.

**A**

**Abhilash Thakur** A pivotal figure in the development of the *bīhani kathā* (seed story) or flash fiction form. His works in Videha Sadeha 20 and 24, such as *Sāṃṭha Gāṃṭha* (Collusion) and *Noṭabandī* (Demonetisation), demonstrate an acute mastery of narrative compression and social irony. From a Navya-Nyāya perspective, these stories utilize *pratyakṣa* to capture the instantaneous social disruption caused by policy changes, establishing a *vyāpti* between political action and rural economic vulnerability. The use of irony acts as a *Vakrokti*, where the suggestive power (*Dhvani*) of the text outweighs its literal brevity.

**Acharya Ramanand Mandal** A proponent of Maithili realism and regional assertion. His works include the poetry collection *Bhasa ke na bantiyo* and the

story collection *Raniya Bhikharin*. His writing is analyzed through the Parallel History Framework as a voice of the "Jan Kavi" tradition, prioritizing the linguistic and social realities of the marginalized over Sanskritized academic norms.

**Ajit Kumar Jha** Author of the reflective and autobiographical work *Jatbe Bujhlahun Tatbe Likhlahun*. His contributions are valued for their "unfiltered" *pratyakṣa*, offering a direct testimonial (*śabda*) of the contemporary Maithil experience.

**Amit Mishra** A significant voice in the Maithili Ghazal revival. His work is noted for its adherence to the *Behr* (meter) and *Qaafiyaa* (rhyme) standards established by the Anchinhar movement.

**Amod Kumar Jha** A poet, editor, and critic whose work integrates the *Nāṭyaśāstra's Rasa-Dhvani* aesthetics with a modern, socially critical lens.

**Anand Kumar Jha** Known for research and critical appreciations that bridge the gap between classical Indian performance theory and contemporary Maithili drama.

**Anmol Jha** A contributor to the "Voices from Mithila" series, focused on regional literary sketches and subaltern perspectives.

**Arvind Thakur** The subject of a significant special issue (Issue 438) edited by Ashish Anchinhar, focusing on his contributions to regional Maithili activism and prose.

**Ashish Anchinhar** A central figure in the Videha movement, pioneer of the Anchinhar Aakhar movement for the revitalization of the Maithili Ghazal. His theoretical work, *Maithili Ghazalak Vyakarana o Itihasa*, provided the first systematic grammar for the genre in Maithili. His poetry is characterized by *Lāghava* (logical parsimony) and a sharp focus on *Dhvani*.

**Ashok** A multifaceted writer and editor. His works in the archive include *Nava Kavita*, the satire collection *Neek Dinak Bioscope*, and the critical study *Katha-Path*. His editing of the journals *Sandhan* and *Pratiman* is treated as an exercise in *Pratyakṣa-based* curation, favoring social realism over romanticized tropes.

**B**

**Bechan Thakur** A pioneer of the Videha Maithili Parallel Theatre Movement. His work is analyzed through the lenses of Brecht, Boal, and the *Nāṭyaśāstra*, representing a "theatre from below" that challenges the elite Darbhanga-centric dramatic tradition.

**Bhavnath Jha** A scholar, epigraphist, and manuscriptologist whose contributions to cultural preservation are documented in the *Videha Bhavnath Jha Special Issue* (Issue 427). His work is analyzed as a bridge between the traditional scholarship of the Navya-Nyāya logicians and modern digital archiving.

**Binay Bhushan** Featured in Part 72 of the Parallel History series for his research and literary contributions that integrate historical regional data with creative expression.

**Bindeshwar Thakur** A contributor to the critical research on modern Maithili realism and its regional variations across Bihar and Nepal.

**C**

**Chandan Kumar Jha** A prominent Ghazalist whose work illustrates the expansion of the Maithili Ghazal into social and devotional spheres.

**D**

**Dinesh Kumar Mishra** A civil engineer whose research on Mithila's rivers is treated as a landmark in "Ecological Maithili Literature". His works, such as *The Kamla River and People on Collision Course* and *Bandini Mahananda*, provide a scientific *pratyakṣa* of the failure of centralized embankments, which he labels an "engineering sin". His writing is considered to have high "literary value" because it preserves the "memory" of the people in the face of environmental displacement.

**Durganand Mandal** A researcher who utilizes *Rasa-Dhvani* aesthetics to provide critical appreciations of subaltern prose, particularly the works that document the lives of the Mushahar and Dalit communities.

**G**

**Gajendra Thakur** The editor of Videha and the primary architect of the Parallel History Framework. His exhaustive output includes the *Ghajalsastram* (the first Maithili-language theoretical manual of the ghazal) and various instructional texts like *Learn Mithilakshar* and *Learn Maithili Sign Language*. His critical appreciations (Parts 1-100 of the Parallel History) constitute a foundational re-reading of Maithili literature through Navya-Nyāya and Subaltern theories.

**Gopalji Jha 'Gopesh'** A poet and cultural critic analyzed in Part 96 for his role in maintaining the continuity of Maithili lyric traditions amidst the pressures of modernization.

**I**

**Ilarani Singh** Jointly researched with Prof. Premshankar Singh, her work is recognized for its academic depth and its role in analyzing the socio-linguistic history of the Maithil community in the twentieth century.

**J**

**Jagdanand Jha "Manu"** A poet, ghazalist, and seed-story writer. His work *Matik Basan* is noted for its groundedness in the material reality of rural Mithila.

**Jagdish Prasad Mandal** A novelist and short-story writer who represents the "farmer-litterateur" perspective. His work is a prime example of Navya-Nyāya *pratyakṣa*, as his social critique emerges from the disciplined observation of agricultural and domestic life.

**K**

**Kailash Kumar Mishra** An anthropologist and writer whose contributions to the *Sadeha* volumes document the cultural rituals and water heritage of Mithila through a scholarly yet literary lens.

**Kalikant Jha ‘Buch’** Analyzed as "The Cursed Poet" in Part 99 of the Parallel History, his work is re-evaluated as a testimonial of internal displacement and the psychological toll of social exclusion.

**Kameshwar Jha 'Kamal'** A writer whose work integrates the Indian *Geet-Sangit* tradition with modern critical theories, particularly focusing on the musicality and rhythmic structures of Maithili verse.

**Kamini Kamayini** A poet whose work is frequently featured in the *Sadeha* archives for its emotive depth and its exploration of the feminine experience in the modern Maithil diaspora.

**Kapileshwar Raut** A writer of stories that focus on the "ordinary" and "marginalized" rural Maithil, often featured in the *Nit Naval* series.

**Kirtinath Jha** A physician and scholar whose translations of Tamil poetry (*Kural*) and Kahlil Gibran (*Tootal Pankhi*) have expanded the thematic horizons of Maithili literature. His original story collection, *Kichhu Puran Gapp, Kichhu Nav Gapp*, is noted for its technical discipline and restraint.

**Kumar Manoj Kashyap** A contributor to contemporary Maithili prose whose work is characterized by its engagement with the "provincial-yet-cosmopolitan" experience of the Maithili diaspora.

**Kusum Thakur** A memoirist and poet whose work provides a unique feminine perspective on the historical and familial structures of Mithila.

**L**

**Lāl Dev Kāmat** A central figure in the democratized wave of Maithili literature. His primary works—*Vibhṛiti*, *Divya Dṛiṣṭi*, *Gahiki Najari*, and *Sheṣ Jīvan*—bridge the gap between literature and practical instruction. His work *Vibhṛiti* (2020) is particularly significant for its integration of organic farming techniques with literary prose poems, embodying the classical concept of *lokahitakārī* (people-benefiting) literature. Through the lens of *Anumāna*, his focus on agricultural self-reliance is seen as a valid inference for regional economic dignity.

**Lallan Prasad Thakur** A playwright and actor whose contributions to the Parallel Theatre movement have helped preserve the folk motifs of Mithila in a modern dramatic context.

**Laxman Jha ‘Sagar’** A Kolkata-based writer and activist whose five decades of work in poetry and short fiction act as an "embodied commitment" to the Maithili cause, especially within the industrial-commercial milieu of the diaspora.

**M**

**Mala Jha** A writer of Maithili fiction whose works are often analyzed in the context of the evolving domestic and social roles of women in Mithila.

**Meena Jha** A pioneer of Maithili social realism and women's medical fiction. Her landmark story on breast cancer is identified as the first in Maithili literature to treat this subject with such depth, predating similar Hindi fiction. Her work is a masterful application of Navya-Nyāya *pratyakṣa*, making speakable what social discourse had previously left unspoken (*śabda*).

**Munni Kamat** A playwright known for the one-act play *Jindagik Mol* and other works that utilize theatre as a tool for social critique.

**Munnaji** Featured in Part 74 of the Parallel History series for research contributions that integrate regional folklore with modern literary criticism.

**N**

**Nagendra Kumar** A poet and scholar analyzed in the collective research of Part 96, recognized for his contribution to the intellectualization of Maithili verse.

**Nand Kumar Mishra 'Nand'** A prolific author of novels, stories, and children's literature whose work spans multiple decades and reflects the changing socio-political landscape of Mithila.

**Nand Vilas Roy** A storyteller and playwright whose contributions to the *Nit Naval* series highlight the resilience of the subaltern voice in the face of economic marginalization.

**O**

**Om Prakash Jha** One of the "Three Voices of the Maithili Ghazal" analyzed in Part 79 for his mastery of ghazal prosody and his role in the form's revival.

**P**

**Preeti Thakur** A pioneer of Maithili children's picture-story literature. Her work is analyzed through children's literature theory and the Parallel History framework, representing a critical intervention in the early literacy and cultural formation of Maithili-speaking children.

**Premshankar Singh** A senior researcher and scholar whose work on the socio-literary history of Maithili has provided a foundation for contemporary parallel history studies.

**R**

**Rajdeo Mandal** A Maithili writer whose poetry and novels represent the authentic subaltern voice. His work is central to the Parallel History series and is often analyzed as a form of "Archival Resistance" against canonical exclusions.

**Ram Vilas Sahu** A storyteller whose works in the *Nit Naval* series are praised for their precise observation of rural life and their grounding in Navya-Nyāya *pratyakṣa*.

**Ramesh Jha** A storyteller whose works explore the psychological and social complexities of the modern Maithil middle class, particularly in the context of migration and urban life.

**Ramesh Narayan** Analyzed alongside other regional poets in Part 96 for his role in sustaining the tradition of Maithili lyricism.

**Ravibhushan Pathak** A translator and researcher whose work in the *Sadeha* volumes focuses on bringing diverse Indian and international literary voices into the Maithili fold.

**S**

**Satyanand Pathak** Author of *Gaam Gel Chhalahun* (The Village has Gone), a work that explores the "Dialectics of Displacement" and the loss of the traditional Maithil village structure.

**Santosh Kumar Mishra** A poet and cultural activist whose work is analyzed for its integration of activist motifs with lyrical beauty.

**Shiv Kumar Jha 'Tillu'** A poet and critic described as a "Cultural Witness" and a "Parallel Voice" of Mithila, whose work provides a lyrical record of social transitions.

**Shivshankar Srinivas** A significant critic and author whose works like *Maithili Upanyasak Alochana* provide the theoretical framework for understanding the evolution of the Maithili novel.

**Subhash Chandra Yadav** A central contemporary figure whose "complete literary works" have been archived and analyzed as part of the *Nit Naval* series, reflecting a commitment to linguistic purity and social realism.

**Sujit Kumar Jha** A journalist and storyteller from Janakpurdham (Nepal). His work is a critical "Nepali-Maithili voice," offering insights into the cross-border cultural continuity of Mithila and the unique challenges faced by the community in the Terai region.

**T**

**Taranand Viyogi** A critic and writer whose analysis, "Beyond the Rhetoric," challenges established literary narratives and focuses on the "fractured voice" of contemporary Maithili experience.

**U**

**Udaya Narayana Singh ‘Nachiketa’** A polymath poet, playwright, and linguist whose contributions are analyzed for their formal innovation and their role in bridging Maithili with global linguistic theories.

**Umesh Mandal** A poet, scholar, and digital pioneer whose work is central to the "democratized wave" of the Videha movement. His stories and critical appreciations are grounded in the epistemological demands of perceiving social truth.

**Umesh Paswan** A Dalit voice in Maithili poetry and fiction. His work is analyzed through the lens of "Dalit Aesthetics" and Navya-Nyāya, representing a radical disruption of the historically brahminical Maithili canon.

**V**

**Vibha Rani** A multifaceted researcher and writer whose work in the Parallel History series explores the intersections of folk traditions, women's performance, and modern realism.

**Vijaynath Jha** A critic and researcher whose appreciations of contemporary Maithili literature focus on the synthesis of traditional *Rasa* theory with modern subaltern themes.

**Vineet Utpal** A scholar and writer whose research on translation theory and the Parallel History framework has helped institutionalize the movement's intellectual goals.

**Y**

**Yogendra Pathak Viyogi** A physicist and science-fiction pioneer who has expanded the thematic boundaries of Maithili literature to include scientific rationalism and speculative narratives.

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**Technical Discourse: Prosody, Formalism, and Navya-Nyāya Logic**

A significant portion of the research in issues 351-438 is dedicated to the formal restoration of Maithili literary genres. The Anchinhar Aakhar movement, in particular, represents a rigorous application of prosodic grammar to the Maithili Ghazal. The following table contrasts the classical requirements of the ghazal form with the specific Maithili implementations advocated by the movement.

| Element of Ghazal Prosody | Classical Requirement (Aruz) | Maithili Implementation (Anchinhar) | Critical Epistemological Note |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Sher (Couplet)** | Emotional independence (*wahdat al-bayt*). | Strictly maintained as the fundamental compositional unit. | Aligns with the *Lāghava* (parsimony) of Navya-Nyāya logic. |
| **Behr (Meter)** | Fixed quantal patterns (e.g., Arabic- | 19 identified Maithili Bahars, including *Bahar-e-* | Use of numerical *matrakram* for teaching provides |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| | Urdu origins). | *Videha*. | logical precision. |
| **Qaafiyaa (Rhyme)** | Systematic consonant-vowel recurrence. | Precision in Maithili script; rejection of surface rhyme without phonological patterning. | A manifestation of *avacchedakatva*—delimiting valid rhyme. |
| **Radif (Refrain)** | Identical word or phrase after Qaafiyaa. | Adapted to Maithili postpositions (e.g., *-ke*, *-e*); resonates with folk *teka*. | Connects modern formalism with indigenous *śabda-pramāṇa*. |
| **Matla (Opening)** | Both lines must carry rhyme and refrain. | Strictly enforced foundation; failure is seen as a fundamental logical error. | Establishes the sonic *vyāpti* for the entire poem. |

**Ecological Realism and the Literature of Water: The Work of Dinesh Kumar Mishra**

The integration of Dinesh Kumar Mishra's engineering and historical research into the Videha archive (analyzed in Issues 360-390 and Sadeha 29) represents a major shift in what constitutes "literature" within the parallel framework. Mishra's work is not merely technical; it is a narrative of collision between traditional wisdom (*ahar-pyne* systems) and flawed modern engineering.

His analysis of the Mahananda and Kamla rivers uses a scientific *pratyakṣa* to demonstrate how embankments destroy the agricultural cycle by trapping silt and raising riverbeds. From the perspective of the Parallel History Framework, this is "literature from below" that documents agrarian suffering in visceral detail, much like the colonial-era protest poetry of Faturilal. Mishra's

philosophy of "Living with Floods" is seen as a literary and ethical imperative for a society whose culture and identity are inseparable from its rivers. The "literary theft" controversy involving his book *Dui Patan Ke Bich Mein* further proves the profound value of his research as a source of creative and political inspiration.

**Social Realism and the Feminine "Unwriteable": The Contribution of Meena Jha**

The critical appreciation of Meena Jha (Sadeha 31 and Issue 420) focuses on her role as a pioneer of women's social realism. Her fiction is grounded in *vishiṣṭa-pratyakṣa*, where the universal social condition of Maithil women—their domestic isolation, their health crises, and their economic dependency—is revealed through the pressure of precise particular observation.

Her breast cancer story is a landmark achievement, marking the entry into the literary archive of a subject that the "canonical tradition's silence had rendered unwriteable". Applying Navya-Nyāya, this is an act of resolving a crisis of *śabda* (verbal testimony), where the writer makes speakable what society had suppressed. Her characters often occupy a "middle path," creating an inferential structure (*anumāna*) that invites the reader to explore social truths between established ideological poles.

**Conclusion: The Digital Resurgence and the Democratic Canon**

The research into Videha issues 351-438 reveals a movement that has successfully transformed Maithili literature from a caste-stratified academic pursuit into a vibrant, democratic, and intellectually rigorous digital archive. By reclaiming the logic of Gaṅgeśa and the social realism of the "Parallel Tradition," the Videha movement has provided a robust framework for linguistic revitalization.

The alphabetical compendium of authors demonstrates a remarkable diversity of voices—from engineers like Dinesh Kumar Mishra and physicists like Yogendra Pathak Viyogi to Dalit poets like Umesh Paswan and diaspora voices like Laxman Jha 'Sagar'. This inclusive approach, supported by the precision of Navya-Nyāya and the critical depth of the Parallel History Framework, ensures that Maithili literature is no longer a peripheral curiosity but a major vehicle for intellectual engagement with the modern world. The ongoing documentation of these issues on www.videha.co.in continues to preserve the "memory" of Mithila while paving the way for a more equitable and creative future.

ADDENDUM

**The Architecture of Archival Resistance: A Comprehensive Analysis of the Videha e-Journal and the Parallel Maithili Tradition (Issues 1–438)**

The digital transformation of Maithili literature finds its most significant manifestation in the "Videha" e-journal, a platform that has redefined the boundaries of linguistic identity and literary historiography. Since its inception, Videha has served not merely as a repository of texts but as an active participant in the construction of a "Parallel Tradition". This movement seeks to challenge the established, often caste-centric, Maithili literary canon by emphasizing subaltern voices, regional variations in Nepal and Assam, and the democratization of knowledge through digital accessibility. The archive, spanning from the first issue in 2008 to issue 438, encapsulates a longitudinal study of how a language can be revitalized by looking beyond traditional institutional gatekeeping. The overarching philosophy of this endeavor is rooted in the necessity of creating a history that represents the "ignored and non-represented" aspects of society, a goal achieved through thematic special issues, invited critical series like "Nit Naval," and curatorial selections that highlight the cutting edge of Maithili modernism.

**The Philosophical and Historiographical Foundations of the Parallel Tradition**

The "Parallel History of Maithili Literature" is a corrective project aimed at dismantling the "obscurantist" structures that have historically marginalized liberal and subaltern writers. Central to this critique is the legacy of Harimohan Jha (1908–1984), a novelist and satirist whose direct attacks on caste orthodoxy and Brahmin hypocrisy led to his systematic exclusion from institutional accolades like the Sahitya Akademi Award. The archive posits that the refusal to honor Jha in 1967 was a seminal moment that revealed the caste-based selection templates of the era. In response, the Parallel Tradition reclaims the history of Maithili through nine distinct layers, starting with the Buddhist foundations represented by the Charyapadas of the 23 Siddha poets. These 50 texts are treated as the true roots of Maithili lyricism, representing a mobility and resistance to sedentary caste orders that predates the courtly patronage of the Karnat and Oinwar dynasties.

This historiographical shift also involves the "reclaiming" of Vidyapati. In the Parallel Tradition, Vidyapati is viewed through a subaltern lens, as evidenced by the Videha movement’s logo, which depicts a version of the poet whose caste status is historically uncertain and who is contested as an elite

appropriation. This version of Vidyapati stands in contrast to the Brahmin-centric organizations that have "invested" him with elite status to bolster social hierarchies. The "Dooshan Panji" or Blackbook, digitized and released by Videha in 2009, serves as a primary tool of archival resistance, exposing genealogical "secrets" such as the marriage of the philosopher Gangesh Upadhyaya to a woman from a lower caste (Charmkarini), a fact reportedly suppressed by traditional historians like Ramanath Jha.

**Chronological Evolution of the Maithili Linguistic Identity**

| Language Period | Timeline | Characteristics and Developmental Impact |
|---|---|---|
| Proto-Maithili | 700–1300 AD | Origins of subaltern linguistic resistance; mobility over sedentary caste order. |
| Early Maithili | 1300–1600 AD | Rise of regional dynasties; courtly patronage; suppression of vernacular realism. |
| Middle Maithili | 1600–1830 AD | The "Great Diaspora"; decline in the heartland; flourishing in Nepal and Assam. |
| Modern Maithili | 1830–Present | Institutional revival; language-dialect debates; emergence of digital democratization. |

**The Videha-Sadeh Archive: Detailed Analysis of the 37 Special Issues**

The "Videha-Sadeh" series constitutes the most vital thematic collection within the journal, extracting and refining the best compositions from the first 350 issues. These 37 special issues are organized into two primary categories: those focusing on general excellence in prose and poetry (Issues 1–25) and those centered on specific themes, translations, and pedagogical materials (Issues 26–37). Each issue is meticulously curated to serve both the academic community and students preparing for competitive examinations, particularly the UPSC Maithili Compulsory paper. The script versatility of these issues—available in both Devanagari and Tirhuta (Mithilakshar)—reflects a commitment to linguistic continuity and script preservation.

**Detailed List of the 37 Videha Special Issues (विशेषांक)**

**The "Videha Visheshank" (Special Issue) series represents a targeted effort to archive specific genres, movements, and authors within the**

**Parallel Tradition. These 37 issues, spanning from the journal's early days to the present, provide a thematic roadmap of the Videha era.**

| No. | Special Issue (विशेषांक) | Date / Issue Context |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | Haiku Visheshank | 15 June 2008 |
| 2 | Ghazal Visheshank | 01 November 2008 |
| 3 | Beehani Katha Visheshank | 01 October 2010 |
| 4 | Bal Sahitya Visheshank | 15 November 2010 |
| 5 | Natak Visheshank | 15 December 2010 |
| 6 | Samiksha Visheshank | 15 January 2011 |
| 7 | Nari Visheshank | 01 March 2011 |
| 8 | Anuvad Visheshank (Gadya-Padya Bharati) | 01 January 2012 |
| 9 | Bal Ghazal Visheshank | 01 August 2012 |
| 10 | Bhakti Ghazal Visheshank | 15 March 2013 |
| 11 | Ghazal Criticism/Review Visheshank | 15 November 2013 |
| 12 | Kashikant Mishra Madhup Visheshank | 01 January 2015 |
| 13 | Arvind Thakur Visheshank (Personality-Work) | 01 November 2015 |

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| **14** | **Jagdish Chandra Thakur Anil Visheshank** | **01 December 2015** |
| **15** | **Videha Samman Visheshank (Award Lists/Interviews)** | **Dec 2011 – April 2016** |
| **16** | **Maithili CD/Album Song Music Visheshank** | **01 January 2017** |
| **17** | **Maithili Web Journalism Visheshank** | **VIDEHA 313** |
| **18** | **Maithili Beehani Katha Visheshank-2** | **VIDEHA 317** |
| **19** | **Ramlochan Thakur Visheshank** | **VIDEHA 319** |
| **20** | **Ramlochan Thakur Tribute Visheshank** | **VIDEHA 320** |
| **21** | **Rajnandan Lal Das Visheshank** | **VIDEHA 333** |
| **22** | **Rabindra Nath Thakur Visheshank** | **VIDEHA 348 (Braille/IPA/Tirhuta)** |
| **23** | **Kedarnath Chaudhary Visheshank** | **VIDEHA 352** |
| **24** | **Premlata Mishra 'Prem' Visheshank** | **VIDEHA 357** |
| **25** | **Shardindu Chaudhary Visheshank** | **VIDEHA 358** |

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| **26** | **Kala-Vimarsh Visheshank (Art Discourse)** | **VIDEHA 368** |
| **27** | **Creator Ashok Visheshank** | **VIDEHA 369** |
| **28** | **Ram Bharos Kapadi 'Bhramar' Visheshank** | **VIDEHA 370** |
| **29** | **Mithila Student Union (MSU) Visheshank** | **VIDEHA 371** |
| **30** | **Lakshman Jha 'Sagar' Visheshank** | **VIDEHA 382** |
| **31** | **Narendra Jha Visheshank** | **Detailed Archive** |
| **32** | **Linguist Ramawatar Yadav Visheshank** | **Detailed Archive** |
| **33** | **Videha Issue 400 (Intl. Maithili Council)** | **15 August 2024** |
| **34** | **Hitnath Jha Visheshank** | **Detailed Archive** |
| **35** | **Mithila Vikas Parishad Visheshank** | **Detailed Archive** |
| **36** | **Narayanji Chaudhary Visheshank** | **Detailed Archive** |
| **37** | **Bhavnath Jha Visheshank / Shivshankar Srinivas** | **Detailed Archive** |

**The Nit Naval (Ever-New) Series: Critical Recovery of Marginalized Voices**

The "Nit Naval" (Ever-New) series is a collection featuring invited works by authors and reviews by invited critics on those works. This initiative acts as a critical bridge between the author and the academic community, ensuring that literature is analyzed within its socio-political context. The series is particularly focused on those entities, individuals, or organizations that have not yet received a dedicated special issue but are essential to the tapestry of the Parallel Tradition. This mechanism of "invited criticism" acts as a form of peer review that circumvents traditional institutional gatekeeping.

The series has been instrumental in the recovery of "suppressed radical modernity," most notably seen in the recovery of Rajkamal Chaudhary's legacy. Through the monograph "Nit Naval Rajkamal" by Subhash Chandra Yadav, Videha has highlighted Chaudhary's role as the true avant-garde of Maithili. The series also recovers democratic voices like Somdev (1934–2022), whose "Aanjur" collection was identified as a critical but long-ignored component of the modern canon.

**The 15 Key Entries of the Nit Naval (Ever-New) Series**

The archive includes 15 key entries that represent invited critiques of authors and literary movements within the Parallel Tradition:

| Entry No. | Author / Focus Area | Critic / Review Context |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | Rajkamal Chaudhary | Monograph by Subhash Chandra Yadav; recovers radical modernity. |
| 2 | Arvind Thakur | Focus on "Swatantracheta"; critical analysis of creative independence. |
| 3 | Sandeep Kumar Safi | Review of the first Dalit autobiography in Maithili. |
| 4 | Somdev | Analysis of the "Aanjur" collection and democratic literature. |
| 5 | Jagdish Chandra Thakur Anil | Exploration of theatre as a tool for social resistance. |
| 6 | Ramlochan Thakur | Tributes and critical reviews of his editorial and activist life. |
| 7 | Rajnandan Lal Das | Analysis of prose contributions to the parallel history. |
| 8 | Rabindra Nath | Criticism of ghazal metrics and formal |

| Entry No. | Author / Focus Area | Critic / Review Context |
|---|---|---|
| | Thakur | poetic structures. |
| 9 | Kedar Nath Chaudhary | Review of regional developments and linguistic standards. |
| 10 | Premlata Mishra 'Prem' | Critical focus on the "Parallel Women Tradition" in verse. |
| 11 | Shardindu Chaudhary | Contemporary poetic reviews focusing on stylistic evolution. |
| 12 | Lakshman Jha 'Sagar' | Philosophical and linguistic studies in parallel tradition. |
| 13 | Narendra Jha | Reviews of theatrical and literary contributions. |
| 14 | Ramawatar Yadav | Review of linguistic standardization and research. |
| 15 | Hitnath Jha | Historical and cultural critiques within the parallel framework. |

**The Editor's Choice and Authorial Advocacy**

The archive also features curated entry points for readers, including the "Editor's Choice" and a dedicated series for authorial self-reviews.

**The Nine Editor's Choice Entries**

The Editor's Choice series acts as a "best-of" curation from the Videha Petar (archive). These entries are selected for their impact on the parallel tradition and their formal excellence.

1. **Series 1:** Creative Prose (Part 1)
2. **Series 2:** Creative Prose (Part 2)
3. **Series 3:** Creative Prose (Part 3)
4. **Series 4:** Creative Prose (Part 4)
5. **Series 5:** Creative Prose (Part 5)
6. **Series 6:** Maithili Prose-Poetry
7. **Series 7:** Sandeep Kumar Safi's "Baishakhme Dalanpar" (First Dalit autobiography in Maithili)
8. **Series 8:** Folk Tales for Children (intended for nighttime storytelling)

9. **Series 9:** Discussion on Maithili Ghazals (critical survey of the history and form)

**The Authorial Advocacy Entries: "Pathak Hamar Pothi Kie Padhrathi"**

The series titled **"Pathak Hamar Pothi Kie Padhrathi"** (पाठक हमर पोथी किए पढ़थि), meaning "Why Should the Reader Read My Book?", serves as a review series where authors provide a critical analysis of their own books and compositions. The documented entries for this series include:

- **Entry 1:** Ashish Anachinhar (आशीष अनचिन्हार) — 01 August 2021.
- **Entry 1(a):** Ashish Anachinhar (आशीष अनचिन्हार) — 01 March 2023.
- **Entry 2:** Gajendra Thakur (गजेन्द्र ठाकुर) — 01 September 2022.

**Linguistic Precision and the Formal Criticism of the Maithili Ghazal**

One of the most rigorous aspects of the Videha archive is its focus on the formal metrics of poetry, particularly the ghazal. In Special Issue 348, dedicated to Rabindra Nath Thakur, the editorial board provides a detailed critique of the technical aspects of contemporary ghazal writing. This level of scrutiny is rare in vernacular digital publishing and serves a vital pedagogical role.

The analysis of ghazals in the archive reveals a high standard for traditional metrics. For example, the critique of Rabindra Nath Thakur’s posthumous collection noted several structural deviations:

- **Radif (Refrain):** 26 ghazals were identified as lacking a consistent radif.
- **Matla (Opening Couplet):** 5 ghazals failed to maintain the required matla structure.
- **Kafiya (Rhyme):** 9 ghazals repeated the same rhyme word (kafiya) across different couplets (shers), and 10 ghazals utilized inappropriate kafiya beyond the opening matla.

**Trans-Regional Dynamics: Maithili in Nepal and Assam**

The Parallel History movement explicitly rejects the heartland-centric view of Maithili literature, documenting instead a "Great Diaspora" where the language flourished in regional courts and monasteries.

**The Nepal-Maithili Tradition**

In the courts of Nepal, Maithili was used as a sophisticated medium for drama and poetry, particularly under the Malla kings.

| Nepal Ruler | Literary Contribution | Impact on Parallel History |
|---|---|---|
| Vishwamalla | Earliest Maithili drama "Vidya Vilap" | Proves the early independence of Maithili theatre. |
| Jagajyotirmalla | Authored "Haragaurivivaha" (1629) | Integrated Shiva-Parvati themes with court drama. |
| Jitamitramalla | Multi-lingual playwright | Demonstrated Maithili's role as a regional bridge. |
| Ranjitamalla | Prolific poet-king | Represented the zenith of the Nepal-Maithili school. |
| Bhupatindra Malla | Composed 26 plays in Maithili | Established Maithili as a dominant courtly language. |

**The Assam-Maithili Tradition: Ankia Nat**

In Assam, the 15th-century reformer Srimanta Sankardeva created a unique hybrid language, Brajavali, based largely on Maithili. The "Ankia Nat" plays archived in Videha, such as "Parijatharan" and "Ramvijay," are treated as essential components of the Maithili literary heritage.

**Technological Sovereignty: Digital Standards and Accessibility**

The Videha archive is a pioneer in digital inclusion. Special Issue 348 (Rabindra Nath Thakur) was released in Braille, alongside versions in the International Phonetic Alphabet (IPA) for linguistic researchers. For academic use, the archive acts as a standardized reference. The "Maithili Spelling - Videha Maithili Standard Language" and the "Maithili Language Editing Course" (Bhashapak) are recognized as sufficient for the UPSC Maithili Compulsory paper, providing a unified orthography for a language that has often suffered from dialectical fragmentation.

**Conclusion: The Enduring Impact of the Videha Era**

The Videha e-journal, through its first 438 issues, has constructed a monumental archive that is both a repository and a revolutionary tool. By documenting 37 thematic special issues, curating the Nit Naval series to provide critical depth, and offering platforms for Dalit and subaltern voices, it has effectively bypassed the traditional structures of literary power. The Parallel Tradition is no longer a peripheral movement but a central pillar of modern Maithili identity.

**LESSON 094 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**

# The Videha Parallel Audio Video Archive: Digital Remediation, Subaltern Historiography, and the Restoration of Maithili Linguistic Sovereignty

WHAT THE CANON LEFT OUT

A Parallel History of Mithila & Maithili Literature

Gajendra Thakur

# The Videha Parallel Audio Video Archive: Digital Remediation, Subaltern Historiography, and the Restoration of Maithili Linguistic Sovereignty

The Videha Parallel Audio Video Archive, hosted as a critical component of the Videha e-journal ecosystem, represents perhaps the most ambitious effort in the twenty-first century to reclaim and preserve the cultural and linguistic heritage of the Mithila region. Founded in 2004 by the polymathic editor Gajendra Thakur, the archive operates under the auspices of the first Maithili fortnightly e-journal (ISSN 2229-547X), which has consistently challenged the centralized, elite-caste hegemony of state-sponsored literary academies. The archive is not merely a repository of media files; it is the digital manifestation of a broader intellectual movement known as "Parallel Literature." This movement seeks to provide an alternative to the official Maithili canon, which is often perceived as having been sanitized of its subaltern, feminist, and trans-regional complexities. By leveraging the decentralized nature of the internet, the Videha archive has bypassed traditional institutional gatekeepers to create a living, democratic institution that serves the Maithili-speaking population of both India and Nepal, as well as the global diaspora.

**Historical and Sociological Foundations of the Parallel Movement**

To understand the necessity of the Videha Parallel Audio Video Archive, one must first examine the historical and sociological landscape of Mithila. Historically identified with the ancient kingdom of Videha—the homeland of Sita and the intellectual cradle of the Navya Nyāya school of logic—Mithila has long been a center of Indian civilization. However, the modern history of the Maithili language has been marked by significant stratification. Since the language’s inclusion in the Eighth Schedule of the Indian Constitution in 2003, the literary establishment has often remained under the control of patronage networks that marginalize non-represented castes and voices.

The "Parallel History" framework, which underpins the archive, was developed as a direct response to this exclusion. As noted by sociologists such as T.K. Oommen, the Maithili region has historically been economically and culturally dominated by specific social strata, which has occasionally led to the suppression of vernacular realism in favor of a courtly or priestly elite narrative. The Videha movement draws inspiration from the *Narashanshi* referred to in the Vedas as a form of parallel literature, asserting that the true roots of Maithili

culture lie in a "foundational democratic-spiritual corpus" rather than in the exclusive preserves of royal courts.

| Linguistic Period | Developmental Stage | Key Characteristics in Parallel History |
|---|---|---|
| 500 BC - 100 BC | Pali (Early Prakrit) | Canonical Buddhist language; early vernacular shifts. |
| 100 BC - 500 AD | Middle Indo-Aryan | Dramatic Prakrits; emergence of popular speech forms. |
| 500 AD - 1100 AD | Apabhramsa/ Avahatta | Transitional "popular" speech; Buddhist Charyapadas. |
| 1100 AD - Present | New Indo-Aryan | Emergence of Maithili, Bengali, and Assamese as distinct entities. |

The Videha archive seeks to document this "Parallel Tradition" through a multi-layered historiography. This includes the reclaiming of the 50 Charyapadas of 23 Siddha poets (such as Luipada and Saraha) as the true ancestors of the Maithili lyric, rather than treating them as peripheral curiosities of Old Bengali or Assamese. This repositioning is critical, as it shifts the origin of Maithili literature from the 14th-century court of Vidyapati to a much earlier, subaltern, and spiritually democratic milieu.

**Technical Architecture and Multimedia Preservation**

The technical infrastructure of the Videha Parallel Audio Video Archive is designed to address the specific needs of a low-resource language while ensuring maximum accessibility for a diverse user base. The archive handles a variety of media formats, including digital e-books, graphic novels, audio recordings, and video documentaries. This multimedia approach is not merely aesthetic; it is a strategic response to the declining literacy in the original Tirhuta script and the "invasion" of Hindi and Nepali media.

One of the most innovative features of the archive is the "Maithili Read Aloud & Sign Language" project. By producing video content that incorporates sign language and audible readings of canonical and contemporary texts, the archive ensures that the Maithili digital renaissance is inclusive of persons with disabilities. This initiative aligns with the editor's commitment to accessibility, as the contents are periodically checked for technical issues that might hinder users with visual or auditory impairments.

The archive also serves as a vital platform for the preservation of oral traditions. Mithila has a rich history of oral narratives, characterized by compression and wit, such as the *Dāka Vachan* and the *Dhūrta Samāgama*. These forms, which prioritize brevity and rhetorical reversal, find their modern descendants in the "Seed Stories" (*Bīhani Kathā*) archived on Videha. By recording and archiving these oral performances, Videha preserves the melodic and rhythmic nuances of the Maithili language that are often lost in purely textual transcriptions.

**Documentation of Folk Arts and Ritual Performance**

A significant portion of the video archive is dedicated to the documentation of Mithila’s ritualistic paintings and folk songs. The "Parallel" view of Mithila art emphasizes its role as a living, democratic practice rather than a static aesthetic category. The archive documents various forms of art, including:

- **Bhittichitra (Wall Painting):** Specifically the *Kohbar Ghar* (nuptial room) murals that are traditionally created by women to symbolize fertility and joy.
- **Aripana (Floor Art):** Ritualistic drawings created during festivals and life-cycle ceremonies.
- **Pata-Chitra (Canvas Painting):** More contemporary adaptations of traditional motifs.

The archive systematically records the songs associated with these rituals, which are often passed down verbally across generations in the woman-dominated space of the *Angana* (courtyard). By digitizing these performances, Videha counters the "usurpation" of these traditions by commercial interests and ensures that the specific cultural meanings of motifs like the *Kalash* (sacred pot) or the *Sita-Ram* narrative remain rooted in their local context.

| Notable Artist/Singer | Contribution Category | Significance in Archive |
|---|---|---|

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| Sita Devi | Mithila Painting | National award-winning artist from Jitwarpur; pioneer of the form. |
| Ravindra Nath Thakur | Song/Drama | Conferred title "Abhinav Vidyapati"; transformed Maithili performance culture. |
| Maithili Thakur | Contemporary Folk | Popularized Maithili songs for the digital-native generation. |
| Sharda Sinha | Folk Music | Renowned for wedding and festival songs; "Bihar Kokila." |

**The Maithili CD/Album Renaissance: Issue 217 and Critical Musicology**

A landmark moment in the archive's documentation of Maithili music is Videha Issue 217 (January 2017), a special issue dedicated to Maithili CDs and albums. This issue serves as a critical survey of the "Geet-Sangeet" landscape, providing both a technological record of digital releases and a sociological critique of the music industry in Mithila and Nepal.

**The State of Maithili Music in Nepal**

Contributor Dinesh Yadav provides a stark assessment of Maithili music in Nepal, noting that while the region is rich in artists like Udit Narayan Jha and Muralidhar, the industry is plagued by "syndicates" and institutional neglect. Yadav critiques the "baniya-giri" (commercialism) where institutional funds meant for the promotion of Vidyapati’s music are often mired in controversy and caste-based favoritism. The archive highlights the transition of Maithili music into the digital era, noting that while recording studios are proliferating, the lack of professional training for new entrants has led to the "invasion" of Hindi and Bhojpuri influences on the authentic Maithili "flavor".

**Standardization of the Mithila Anthem**

A key intellectual proposal in Issue 217 is Yogendra Pathak 'Viyogi's' call for the standardization of the *Bhagwati Vandana* ("Jai Jai Bhairavi"). Viyogi argues that just as "Jana Gana Mana" serves as a unified national anthem with a

standard melody, "Jai Jai Bhairavi" should have a simplified, standard tune that allows all Maithils to participate in unison during public gatherings, rather than being subjected to the complex improvisations of individual performers that hinder collective participation.

**Archival Listings of Folk and Devotional Albums**

Issue 217 provides an exhaustive list of Maithili CDs and albums that have shaped the contemporary auditory landscape :

- **Folk and Ritual Songs:** The archive preserves the work of Jage Mahto and Jage Raut (*Karik Jhumar, Sokha Jhumar*) and Birasi Sada, whose recordings of songs for *Gahil Mata* and *Bhuinya Baba* represent the subaltern spiritual traditions of the region.
- **The "Bihar Kokila" Legacy:** Ira Mallik provides a descriptive survey of Sharda Sinha's "Vivah-Geet" album, listing 16 traditional wedding songs categorized into Side A and Side B, such as "Aaj Dhanma Kuta-u Raghubarba San" and "More Babua Ko Nazariyo Na Lage".
- **Classical-Folk Synthesis:** Dr. Kailash Kumar Mishra explores the work of Prof. Chandeshwar Jha, who utilized CDs and DVDs to preserve folk Maheshbanis and Bhagwati Vandanas set to classical ragas, such as *Jogiya Mor Jagat Sukhadayak* and *Sabahak Sudhi Aha Lai Chhi He Ambe*.
- **The Ghazal Influence:** The album *Sinehiya* by Kunj Bihari Mishra is reviewed by Pradeep Pushpa as a significant experiment in the Maithili ghazal-style song, though it notes the technical challenges of maintaining formal prosody (*Behr* and *Qaafiya*) in modern pop recordings.

**Children's Media and the Archival Gap**

Gajendra Thakur highlights a "complete lack" of dedicated Maithili CD albums for children, identifying this as a major threat to linguistic transmission across generations. The archive attempts to fill this gap by documenting and providing links to the few existing resources, such as Ramesh Ranjan's plays and the *Bal Mandali* recordings.

**The Anchinhar Movement: Restoring the Maithili Ghazal**

The Videha archive has been instrumental in the revitalization of the Maithili ghazal through the "Anchinhar Aakhar" (Unfamiliar Word) movement. Launched on April 11, 2008, this movement sought to correct a "dark interlude" in Maithili literary history during which the formal constraints of the ghazal—such as *Behr* (meter) and *Qaafiyaa* (rhyme)—were largely abandoned. This

technical decline had led to the marginalization of legitimate poets who maintained rigorous standards, such as Vijaynath Jha and Yoganand Heera.

Gajendra Thakur, acting as Maithili's first "Aruji" (prosody expert), authored the *Ghajalsastram*, the first comprehensive theoretical manual of the ghazal in the Maithili language. This manual, archived on the Videha site, explains the Arabic and Persian genealogy of the form and provides a systematic framework for its adaptation to Maithili phonetics. The Anchinhar movement successfully brought 350 to 400 new and previously marginalized writers into the literary mainstream within a single decade by providing them with the technical tools to master the form.

The archive documents the "legitimate lineage" of Maithili ghazal writers, tracing the form from its earliest experiments by Pandit Jivan Jha in the early 20th century through to modern masters. Ashish Anchinhar, a key figure in this movement, is credited with constructing new *Bahars* (meters) specific to Maithili, expanding the genre into children's literature and devotional verse. This formalist revival is viewed as a "structural act of literary justice," reclaiming the ghazal as a site of technical excellence rather than a tool for caste-based gatekeeping.

| **Ghazal Component** | **Technical Definition** | **Role in Maithili Reform** |
|---|---|---|
| Behr | Rhythmic meter. | Restored to ensure musicality and formal rigour. |
| Qaafiyaa | Rhyme. | Standardized to prevent "weak era" inaccuracies. |
| Radif | Refrain. | Integrated with Maithili phonetics for consistent structure. |
| Matla | The opening couplet. | Used as a benchmark for technical perfection. |
| Maqta | The closing | Includes the poet's *takhallus* |

| | | |
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| | couplet. | (pen name). |

**Script Revitalization and Digital Localization**

One of the most significant technical achievements associated with the Videha Parallel Archive is the revitalization of the Tirhuta (Mithilakshar) script. Tirhuta was the dominant script for Maithili for over a thousand years, used in academic, religious, and genealogical records. However, the 20th century saw its displacement by Devanagari, largely due to the latter's compatibility with modern printing and educational systems.

The Videha movement asserts that linguistic sovereignty is inextricably linked to script sovereignty. To this end, the archive provided the resources and research necessary for the successful proposal to include Tirhuta in the Unicode Standard (encoded in 2014). The site hosts the first Tirhuta-script portal online, along with transliteration tools that allow users to convert text between Tirhuta and 23 other languages. This technical intervention allows for the digital transcription of approximately 11,000 palm-leaf manuscripts, effectively creating a "living parallel institution" that preserves primary historical sources in their original form.

| **Script** | **Domain of Usage** | **Historical Context** | **Current Archival Status** |
|---|---|---|---|
| Tirhuta | Academic/ Religious/Panji. | Dominant 7th-20th century. | Revitalized via Unicode; primary archival script. |
| Kaithi | Trade/ Administration. | Used by Kayastha community. | Studied for historical business records. |
| Newari | Nepal Court Drama. | Malla | Critical for |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | dynasty (1380-1775). | Nepal-Maithili dramas. |
| Devanagari | Education/Modern Media. | Adopted 20th century. | Used for broad accessibility and e-journal issues. |

In addition to script research, Videha has spearheaded localization efforts for Google Translate and Wikipedia. By contributing hundreds of thousands of words to these platforms, the movement ensures that Maithili remains a viable language in the global digital infrastructure. The creation of the first Maithili Braille site further demonstrates the movement's commitment to ensuring that technological progress serves all members of the community, regardless of physical ability.

**Subaltern Historiography and the Dooshan Panji**

The archive’s "Parallel History" project extends into the realm of genealogical research, specifically through the "Dooshan Panji" (The Blackbook). The *Panji Prabandh* is a sophisticated system of genealogical records for Maithil Brahmins and Kayasthas, intended to preserve caste purity. However, the Videha movement critiques this system as a tool of "Brahminical patriarchy" and exclusion.

By digitizing and releasing the "Dooshan Panji" records in 2009, Videha has exposed "secrets" that elite historians reportedly suppressed to maintain social hierarchies. This research reveals documented cases of inter-caste marriages and historical anomalies that challenge the "sacred" basis of elite Maithili identity. For example, the archive provides evidence that the philosopher Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya married a woman from the *Charmkar* (cobbler) community—a fact that complicates the Brahmin-centric narrative of the Navya Nyāya school.

This archival resistance is central to the Videha movement’s mission to reintegrate the "ignored and non-represented" aspects of society into a unified, democratic account of the Maithili-speaking world. By using genealogical

records as a tool for social deconstruction rather than caste preservation, the archive functions as a powerful instrument of social justice.

**The Epistemological Framework: Navya Nyāya and Modern Logic**

A unique aspect of the Videha archive is its engagement with the Navya Nyāya school of Indian logic. The movement argues that the technical apparatus developed by logicians like Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya constitutes an internally coherent system that remains relevant for modern linguistic and critical theory. Concepts such as *śābdabodha* (verbal understanding) and *avacchedaka* (delimitor) are utilized to analyze the structure of cognition and meaning in Maithili literature.

The archive hosts critical appreciations of contemporary writers—such as Shiv Kumar Jha 'Tillu' and Dr. Umesh Mandal—analyzed through the lenses of both Western critical theory and Navya Nyāya epistemology. This synthesis allows for a "synthetic assessment" of literature that respects the indigenous intellectual traditions of Mithila while engaging with global academic standards.

| Navya Nyāya Term | Logical Function | Application in Archival Criticism |
|---|---|---|
| *Avacchedaka* | The delimitor of a property. | Used to define the precise boundaries of literary categories. |
| *Śābdabodha* | Verbal understanding. | Analyzed to understand how texts map the external world. |
| *Viśiṣṭajāna* | Qualificative cognition. | Applied to the structure of poetic metaphors and imagery. |
| *Vyāpti* | Invariable concomitance. | Used in inference-based literary analysis. |

This focus on logic also informs the movement's approach to lexicography. The *Videha English-Maithili Dictionary* and the *Picture Dictionary* by Umesh Mandal use logical categorization to define technical terms and local vocabulary that often lack direct English equivalents. By applying the precision of Navya Nyāya to the challenges of modern translation, the archive strengthens the intellectual foundations of the Maithili language.

**The Nepal-Maithili Legacy and Trans-Regional Identity**

The Videha Parallel Audio Video Archive is distinctive in its refusal to treat the Maithili culture of Nepal as a regional footnote. Instead, it recognizes the Nepal Terai and the Malla-era courts of the Kathmandu Valley as central to the Maithili dramatic and poetic tradition. During the Malla dynasty, Maithili served as the court language and the primary medium for theatre in Kathmandu, Patan, and Bhaktapur.

The archive has digitized numerous Maithili dramas from this period, which are often better preserved in Nepal's manuscript traditions than in the heartland of North Bihar. These plays, such as the 26 dramas composed by Bhupatindra Malla, represent a "Golden Era" of Maithili literature that bridged the gap between Sanskrit classical theatre and vernacular folk forms. By archiving these works, Videha asserts a trans-regional Maithili identity that transcends modern national borders.

| **Nepal Ruler/Patron** | **Literary Contribution** | **Role in Parallel History** |
|---|---|---|
| Jagajyotirmalla | *Haragauriviva ha* (1629). | Integrated Shiva-Parvati themes with court drama. |
| Siddhinara-yanadeva | *Harishchandra - nrityam*. | Multilingual drama demonstrating Maithili's regional reach. |
| Ranjit Malla | 19 identified plays. | Represented the zenith of the Nepal-Maithili school. |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| Vishwamalla | *Vidya Vilap*. | Earliest extant Maithili drama from Nepal. |

This focus on Nepal also includes contemporary figures such as Ram Bharos Kapari 'Bhramar' and Sujit Kumar Jha, whose journalism and storytelling are archived as essential voices of the Nepal-Maithili experience. The archive serves as a vital bridge between the Maithili-speaking communities of India and Nepal, fostering a unified linguistic community.

**Contemporary Prose: The Bīhani Kathā and Modern Realism**

The Videha archive is a major institutional home for contemporary Maithili fiction, particularly the *Bīhani Kathā* (Seed Story). This genre, characterized by its extreme brevity and "seed-like" potentiality, was popularized through the e-journal and its canonical anthology, *Videha Sadeha 5*. These stories often break away from the traditional erotic and devotional molds of Maithili literature to tackle stark social realities.

Writers like Rajdeo Mandal and Jagdish Prasad Mandal are celebrated in the archive for representing the subaltern voice in modern fiction. Their works, along with those of Bechan Thakur, are identified by the Parallel History movement as the "truly great contemporary voices" that have been ignored by official government academies. The archive provides these writers with a global platform, ensuring that their critiques of caste, economic struggle, and social injustice are heard.

| **Contemporary Writer** | **Primary Form** | **Themes/Significance** |
|---|---|---|
| Rajdeo Mandal | Novel/ Poetry | Subaltern resistance and rural realism. |
| Jagdish Prasad Mandal | Short Story/Fiction | Critique of patriarchal structures and social exclusion. |
| Bechan Thakur | Novel/ Drama | Regarded by Videha as one of the greatest living Maithili writers. |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| Rabindra Narayan Mishra | Novel/ Memoir | Institutional justice and individual conscience. |

The archive's collection of contemporary prose also includes experimental works such as the first Maithili graphic novel, *Sahasrabadhani* (The Comet), by Gajendra Thakur. By embracing new media and experimental forms, the archive demonstrates that Maithili is a language capable of modern innovation.

**Comparative Literary Influence: Maithili, Bengali, and Assamese**

The Videha archive places Maithili within a broader "pan-eastern" literary context, documenting its profound influence on the development of Bengali and Assamese literatures. The archive features studies on the "Brajabuli" and "Brajavali" traditions—hybrid literary languages modeled on Vidyapati's Maithili lyrics—which became the liturgical medium for Vaishnavism in Bengal and Assam.

The archive documents how figures like Govindadasa Kabiraja and Srimanta Sankaradeva adopted Maithili forms to create some of the most enduring works of eastern Indian literature. This comparative perspective is vital for challenging the perception of Maithili as a minor dialect; instead, it reveals Maithili as a foundational "literary sun" that illuminated the surrounding regional traditions for centuries.

| **Tradition** | **Key Figures** | **Maithili Influence** |
|---|---|---|
| Bengali Brajabuli | Govindadasa Kabiraja, Rabindranath Tagore. | Modeled on Vidyapati's Padavali; used for devotional lyrics. |
| Assamese Brajavali | Sankaradeva, Madhavadeva. | Used in *Ankianata* dramas; modeled on Maithili prosody. |
| Kirtaniya Natak | Umapati Upadhyaya. | Earliest Maithili-Sanskrit hybrid drama form. |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| Nepal Court Drama | Malla Kings. | Maithili as the prestige language of Kathmandu theatre. |

The archive also notes that even the great Rabindranath Tagore began his literary career by imitating the style of Vidyapati in his *Bhanusingha Thakurer Padavali*, a hoax that further testifies to the enduring power of the Maithili lyric tradition.

**Future Outlook: The Archive as a Model for Low-Resource Languages**

The Videha Parallel Audio Video Archive serves as a powerful model for how low-resource and marginalized languages can leverage digital technology to achieve cultural sovereignty. By operating as a "decentralized institution," Videha has successfully bypassed the economic and social barriers that often stifle regional literatures.

The archive's future outlook is focused on several key areas:

- **Expansion of Audio-Video Documentation:** Increasing the number of "Read Aloud" videos and documentaries on rural lifestyle and agrarian knowledge.
- **Continued Script Research:** Furthering the implementation of Tirhuta and Kaithi in digital environments to ensure they remain functional for future generations.
- **Strengthening the Digital Diaspora:** Using the e-journal and archive to connect Maithili speakers across India, Nepal, and the global diaspora.
- **Legal and Academic Recognition:** Maintaining the archive as a rigorous academic resource (ISSN 2229-547X) to provide the evidence needed for greater institutional recognition of Maithili's "Parallel History".

The sustainability of this project is driven by a non-commercial ethos, relying on the dedication of scholars and writers who view the preservation of their language as an ethical imperative. As globalization and migration continue to threaten linguistic diversity, the Videha archive stands as a vital defense against the erasure of Mithila's "throbbing human heart".

**Conclusion**

The Videha Parallel Audio Video Archive is a monumental achievement in the field of digital humanities and linguistic preservation. By combining the rigorous logic of Navya Nyāya with the democratic potential of the internet, it has created a space where the marginalized voices of Mithila can reclaim their history. Through its systematic documentation of folk art, its revitalization of

the Tirhuta script, and its courageous critique of social hierarchies via the "Dooshan Panji," Videha has fundamentally reshaped the Maithili literary landscape. It ensures that the language of Janaka and Vidyapati is not just a memory of the past, but a vibrant, living force in the digital age. The archive's success in providing a "clean slate" for Maithili literature demonstrates that even in the face of institutional neglect and social stratification, a language can achieve dignity and vitality through the collective agency of its speakers.

ADDENDUM

# The Singer in the Maithili Parallel Tradition

# Critical Assessment

## 1.1 The Singer in the Maithili Parallel Tradition

The Videha Parallel Literature Movement has consistently included performing artists — singers, actors, theatre workers — within its scope, recognising that Maithili cultural life cannot be reduced to written literature alone. The periodic gatherings represent exactly the kind of democratic, multi-modal cultural space that the Videha movement celebrates: a gathering where poets, critics, theatre workers, and singers meet on equal terms.

The Maithili singing tradition is ancient and central to Mithila's cultural identity — from the Vidyapati padas (songs in the Vidyapati tradition sung across Mithila as religious and seasonal music) to the lokgeet (folk songs), to the more recent classical Maithili song forms. A singer who participates in Maithili literary gatherings bridges the oral and written traditions that the Videha movement sees as inseparable.

## 2.1 Indian Theory: The Singer as Rasa-Medium

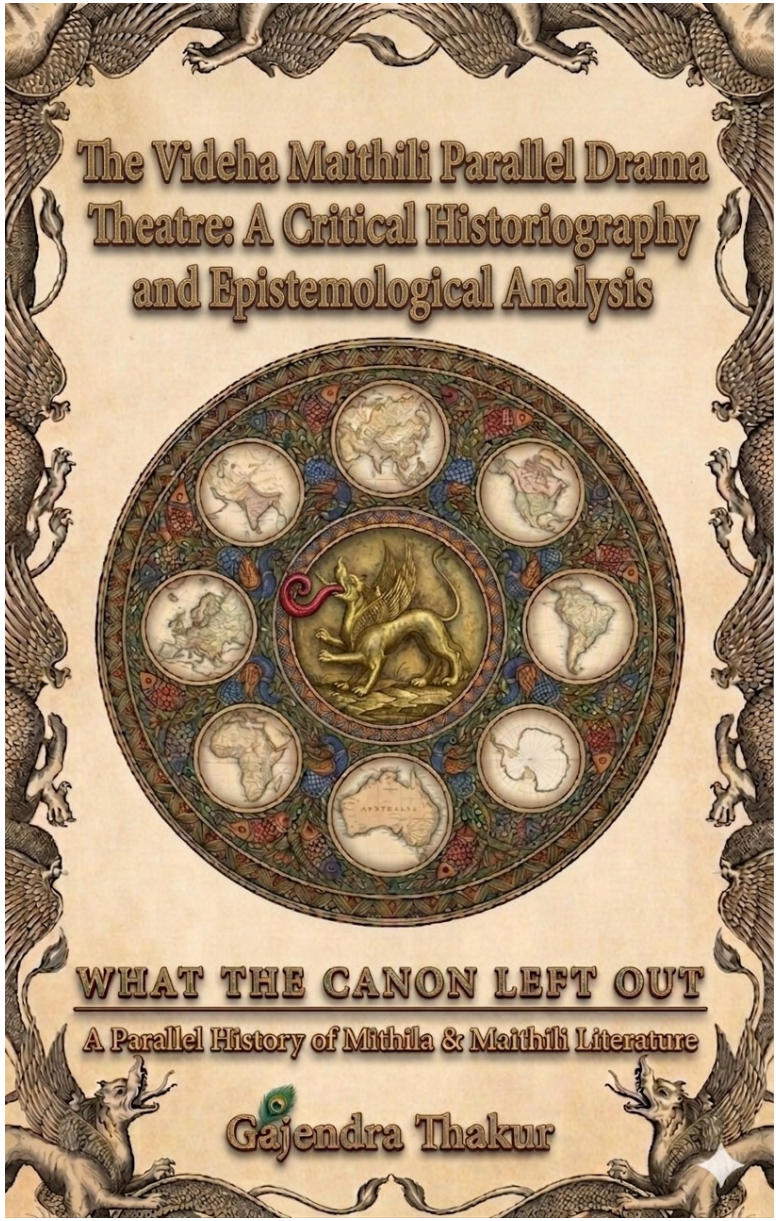
Bharata Muni's Natyashastra identifies song (geet) as one of the four primary vehicles through which rasa is communicated in performance — alongside poetry, dance, and instrumental music. The singer is therefore, in the classical Indian framework, a primary rasa-medium: the one through whose voice the emotional essences of the text are made audible and felt. Rrole as singer at the

gatherings positions one within this classical understanding of the performing artist as rasa-producer.

## 2.2 Navya-Nyaya: Shabda-Pramana through Song

In Gangesa's framework, shabda-pramana (verbal testimony) is the pramana most directly relevant to the singer's art: the singer's performance is a form of shabda that generates valid aesthetic cognition in the audience. The song's text becomes pramana when performed by a qualified singer whose competence (the musicianship and expressive capacity of the apta) makes the shabda aurally and emotionally accessible.

**LESSON 095 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**



# The Videha Maithili Parallel Drama Theatre: A Critical Historiography and Epistemological Analysis

The evolution of Maithili dramatic literature and performance represents a profound nexus of ancient liturgical traditions, medieval courtly spectacles, and a contemporary resurgence defined by radical socio-political critiques. At the heart of this modern cultural landscape is the Videha Maithili Parallel Theatre movement, a decentralized intellectual and artistic initiative that has redefined the boundaries of the Mithila region's cultural identity. This movement does not merely perform plays; it operates within a rigorous, multi-layered framework that synthesizes the formal logical precision of the Navya Nyāya school, the classical performance tenets of Bharata Muni's *Nāṭyaśāstra*, and the critical insights of Western postmodern and post-colonial theories. By positioning itself as a "parallel" tradition, it systematically challenges the caste-centric, institutionalized narratives that have historically dominated Maithili letters, specifically critiquing the aesthetic and linguistic hegemony sanctioned by mainstream bodies such as the Sahitya Akademi.

**Contextual Foundations: The Concept of Parallel Literature**

The term "Parallel Maithili Literature" (*Samanantar Maithili Sahitya*) identifies a stream of creative production that exists independently of traditional patronage networks and elite caste-based literary establishments. This tradition has found its most potent expression through the digital and archival intervention of the *Videha* e-journal, established in 2004, which asserts that the officially recorded history of Maithili literature is frequently a history of exclusion and erasure. Under the theoretical leadership of Gajendra Thakur, the movement has meticulously chronicled segments of society—including Dalits, women, and rural laborers—whose voices were previously relegated to the peripheral margins of the Maithili canon.

Historically, Mithila—the ancient kingdom of Videha—has served as a pivotal center of Indian civilization, producing foundational works in Sanskrit logic (*Navya Nyāya*) and the devotional lyrical poetry of Vidyāpati. However, the modern era witnessed a significant stratification of this heritage. The institutional history, often mediated through influential figures like Ramanath Jha, prioritized a high-born, Sanskritized aesthetic while neglecting the organic, subaltern traditions of the broader linguistic community. The Videha movement seeks to dismantle this hegemony, arguing that the true vitality of the Maithili language resides in its democratic reach and its ability to represent the

material conditions of the masses rather than the nostalgic preoccupations of an elite enclosure.

This transition from a "museumized" culture to a living, "parallel" theatre was necessitated by the perceived failure of mainstream theatre to address contemporary regional crises, such as the collapse of the agrarian economy, large-scale migration, and the persistence of what the movement identifies as "social diseases" (*Sāmājik Roga*) inherent in the caste system.

| **Movement Dimension** | **Institutional/Mainstream Tradition** | **Videha Parallel Movement** |
|---|---|---|
| **Socio-Political Base** | Caste-centric, Elite-patronized | Subaltern-led, Democratic, Grassroots |
| **Linguistic Identity** | Sanskritized, Homogenized, Hindi-influenced | Authentic Vernacular, Tirhuta-centric |
| **Theoretical Anchor** | Lyrical Nostalgia, Status Quo | Navya Nyāya Logic, Social Realism |
| **Medium of Distribution** | Institutional Print, Academia | E-journals, Digital Archives, Folk Troupes |
| **Historical View** | Linear, Hegemonic, Brahmin-centric | Multi-vocal, Revisionist, Subaltern |

**The Videha Parallel History Framework: A New Historiographical Methodology**

The "Videha Parallel History Framework" is a critical-historical methodology developed within the *Videha* movement to provide an alternative narrative to the mainstream construction of Mithila's past. Most fully articulated by Gajendra Thakur in his series "Parallel Literature in Maithilī and Videha Maithilī Literature Movement," this framework posits that linguistic identity is a field of struggle (*Kṣetra*). The framework argues that the loss of a language's indigenous script (Tirhuta) and its surrender to external linguistic structures, particularly Hindi-calques, is functionally equivalent to the loss of a kingdom.

**Revisionist Historiography and Institutional Critique**

A central intervention of the Parallel History Framework is the systematic exposure of institutional biases and erasures in Maithili literary historiography. A notable example is the framework's documentation of the "honor killing" of the legacy of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya, the 12th-century philosopher who founded the Navya Nyāya school. While institutional historians celebrate Gaṅgeśa for his *Tattvacintāmaṇi*, they often suppress biographical details that complicate the narrative of caste purity—specifically, that Gaṅgeśa married a woman from the "Charmkarini" (leather-worker) caste and that his descendants faced social exclusion as a result. By unearthing these suppressed narratives, the framework demonstrates how the *Panji* system (the sophisticated genealogical record-keeping of Maithil Brahmins) was historically used as a tool of social engineering and cultural gatekeeping.

Furthermore, the framework re-evaluates the trajectory of Maithili drama, identifying an indigenous lineage of "absurdity" that predates Western influence. It traces a full historical circle from the medieval absurdity and social satire found in Jyotirishwar's 13th-century *Dhūrtasamāgama* to the contemporary postmodern absurdity of works like Nachiketa's *No Entry: Mā Praviśa*. This re-centering of absurdity as a native Maithili dramatic trait allows the movement to claim modernism not as a foreign import but as a recovered heritage.

**The Exposure of the "Black Book"**

A pivotal moment in the parallel historiography was the 2009 release and digitization of the "Black Book" of genealogical records (*Dooshan Panji*), which documented historical "defects" or social transgressions within elite families. By making these secret records public, the Videha movement sought to dismantle the myths of ancestral purity that sustained the contemporary literary establishment's exclusionary practices. This act of digital activism provided the empirical basis for a broader critique of institutional "booty

distribution," referring to the perceived nepotism in Sahitya Akademi awards where popular subaltern voices like the satirist Harimohan Jha were historically overlooked in favor of less relevant academic texts.

**Epistemological Foundations: The Application of Navya Nyāya to Drama**

The most intellectually distinctive feature of the Videha movement is its application of the technical apparatus of Navya Nyāya (New Logic) to literary criticism and performance theory. Traditionally, Navya Nyāya—consolidated by Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya in Mithila during the 14th century—was reserved for dry theological and metaphysical debates. The Videha movement, however, utilizes its rigorous epistemological categories to evaluate the "truth-value" and structural integrity of dramatic representation.

**The Technical Apparatus of Gaṅgeśa**

In his *Tattvacintāmaṇi*, Gaṅgeśa identifies four *pramāṇas* (valid sources of knowledge): *Pratyakṣa* (perception), *Anumāna* (inference), *Upamāna* (comparison), and *Śabda* (verbal testimony). The Maithili Parallel Theatre applies these categories to determine whether a dramatic work accurately "tracks" the social world as it exists.

**1. Pratyakṣa (Qualified Perception):** Navya Nyāya defines *Pratyakṣa* not as simple sensory experience but as *Viśiṣṭa-pratyakṣa*—the cognitive act of perceiving the universal (*sāmānya*) through the specific (*viśeṣa*). In the context of parallel theatre, this serves as the epistemological foundation for social realism. When a play depicts the specific suffering of a rural laborer or a marginalized woman (the *viśeṣa*), it is judged successful only if it allows the audience to perceive the universal social structures (the *sāmānya*) that produce that suffering. For example, the works of Meena Jha use precise domestic observation to make visible the universal patriarchal constraints of Maithili society.

**2. Anumāna and Vyāpti (Inference and Concomitance):** The logic of *Anumāna* depends on *vyāpti*, the invariable relationship between a mark (*hetu*) and the thing to be proved (*sādhya*). Parallel critics use this to test the internal consistency of dramatic characters and plots. If a play claims to represent "village life" but uses caricatured linguistic markers or casteist tropes (the *hetu*), the critic infers a "casteist consciousness" (the *sādhya*) that invalidates the play’s claim to social truth. This method provides a logical basis for rejecting the "slapstick humor" of mainstream Maithili theatre as epistemically false.

**3. Avacchedakatva (The Theory of Limitors):** The concept of *avacchedaka* (limiting property) is utilized to define the boundaries of linguistic and cultural identity. The movement argues that institutional Maithili has often lost its *avacchedaka*—the specific phonological and structural features that define it—by adopting Hindi-calques and Sanskritized obfuscations. Parallel Theatre seeks to restore these limitors through the use of authentic, "uncontaminated" Maithili, thereby reclaiming the language as a distinct field of knowledge.

**4. Hetvābhāsa (Logical Fallacies):** The analysis of *hetvābhāsa* (pseudo-reasons) is applied to critique the structural flaws of traditional dramas. Critics identify "unconditional antecedents" or "accidental causes" in mainstream plots—such as sudden, unmotivated changes in character heart or miraculous resolutions—which violate the Nyāya principle of causality. By insisting on a causal logic rooted in material conditions, the parallel movement aligns itself with a more rigorous form of realism.

| Nyāya Category | Definition | Application in Parallel Theatre |
|---|---|---|
| **Pratyakṣa** | Direct Perception | Observational realism; tracking material social conditions. |
| **Anumāna** | Logical Inference | Inferring underlying ideological biases from dramatic choices. |
| **Vyāpti** | Invariable Concomitance | Ensuring structural consistency between character and action. |
| **Avacchedaka** | Limiting Property | Maintaining linguistic purity against Hindi-calque intrusion. |
| **Śābdabodha** | Verbal Understanding | Analyzing the "cognitive report" generated by |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | | dramatic dialogue. |

**Synthesis with Classical Indian Theory: Bharata’s Nāṭyaśāstra**

While the Videha movement is radically modernist in its political orientation, it is deeply conservative—in the original sense of "preserving"—regarding classical performance theory. It advocates for a return to the foundational principles of Bharata Muni’s *Nāṭyaśāstra* to elevate Maithili stagecraft above the "mediocrity" of current institutional theatre.

**The Lokdharmi and Natyadharmi Dialectic**

The *Nāṭyaśāstra* categorizes dramatic performance into two primary modes: *Lokdharmi* (folk/realistic) and *Natyadharmi* (stylized/classical).

- **Lokdharmi:** This mode emphasizes naturalistic acting, simple physical gestures, and the representation of everyday human activities. The Parallel Theatre movement identifies the root of "village drama" (*Gamaiya Natak*) in this mode but seeks to refine it, removing the artificiality and caste-based mockery that has corrupted the contemporary folk stage.
- **Natyadharmi:** This mode utilizes stylized speech (including internal monologues and celestial voices), symbolic gestures, and complex musical structures. The movement's avant-garde productions, such as *Ulkamukha*, employ the *Natyadharmi* style to explore historical and metaphysical themes, using "magic realism" to represent truths that exceed simple observation.

**Performative Excellence and the Sahṛdaya**

Following Chapter 27 of the *Nāṭyaśāstra*, the Parallel Theatre movement defines the success of a performance by its ability to transform the audience into *Sahṛdaya*—those with an empathetic, "same-hearted" connection to the aesthetic experience. The movement explicitly rejects the "performative defects" (*Doshas*) of mainstream theatre, which include grammatical sloppiness, lack of focus, and the use of "corrupt Hindi" to elicit cheap laughter. By adhering to the *Nāṭyaśāstra*'s rigorous standards for *Āṅgika* (body), *Vācika* (voice), *Sāttvika* (emotion), and *Āhārya* (costume/stagecraft), the parallel movement seeks to prove that subaltern theatre can achieve higher artistic standards than elite institutional theatre.

**Performance and Practitioners: The Grassroots Resistance**

The strength of the Maithili Parallel Theatre resides in its decentralized, grassroots structure. The movement has shifted the center of Maithili dramatic

activity away from urban administrative centers to rural villages like Berma and Chanauraganj, where performance is integrated into community life.

**Bechan Thakur: The Director-Educator**

Bechan Thakur is arguably the most significant practitioner of the parallel movement, serving as both a director and a mentor to a new generation of artists. Operating the J.M.S. Coaching Centre in Chanauraganj, Thakur utilizes the theatrical stage as a laboratory for intellectual and linguistic development. His directorial style is characterized by a radical subversion of traditional gender roles; he frequently directs "all-female" productions where women perform both male and female roles. This choice is a conscious inversion of historical traditions like the *Bidapat Nach*, where men impersonated women, and it serves to empower female voices within the Mithila community.

Thakur's productions are noted for their social urgency, addressing themes such as female foeticide, government corruption, and the psychological impact of migration. Students and actors under his tutelage, such as Shobha Kant Mahto and Durga Nand Thakur, view the theatre not merely as entertainment but as a critical duty to save the Maithili language from extinction.

**Jagdish Prasad Mandal: The Farmer-Litterateur**

Jagdish Prasad Mandal embodies the "Parallel" ideal: a writer and playwright deeply rooted in the agrarian life of Berma whose work eschews the aestheticized nostalgia of elite literature. Mandal's plays, including *Mithilak Beti* and *Veerangana*, are foundational texts of social realism in Maithili. His narratives focus on the "material diseases" of society, such as the predatory nature of multinational seed corporations, the collapse of family structures under the weight of the dowry system, and the exploitation of rural labor.

The village of Berma has emerged as a crucial node in the movement, hosting regular "Katha Goshthis" (storytelling circles) where writers like Lakshmi Das and Umash Mandal collaborate with laborers and farmers to produce literature that reflects their lived reality. This collective mode of production ensures that the literature remains a "living" entity rather than a static academic artifact.

| Artist/ Practitioner | Primary Contribution | Key Themes |
|---|---|---|
| **Bechan** | Direction, | Gender subversion, |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **Thakur** | Mentorship, Stage Theory | Social reform, Youth engagement. |
| **Jagdish P. Mandal** | Playwright, Fiction Writer | Agrarian crisis, Subaltern realism, Anti-capitalism. |
| **Gajendra Thakur** | Theory, Historiography, Playwright | Navya Nyāya critique, Revisionist history, Magic realism. |
| **Vibha Rani** | Playwright (*Balchanda*) | Feminist intervention, Foeticide, Domestic agency. |
| **Lakshmi Das** | Satirist, Short Story Writer | Labor rights, Leftist social critique, Bīhani Kathā. |
| **Nachiketa** | Playwright (*No Entry: Ma Pravish*) | Postmodern absurdity, Bureaucratic satire. |

**Textual Analysis: Deep Dives into Representative Plays**

The repertoire of the Maithili Parallel Theatre spans a wide range of genres, from historical revisionist dramas to avant-garde postmodern experiments. Each work serves as a test case for the movement's theoretical synthesis.

**Ulkamukha: Magic Realism and Natyadharmi Prowess**

*Ulkamukha*, written by Gajendra Thakur and directed by Bechan Thakur, represents a landmark in modern Maithili drama for its integration of "magic realism" and classical *Natyadharmi* stagecraft. The play engages with historical and mythological conspiracies, specifically re-interpreting the story of Trisanku and the sage Vishvamitra.

During its performance at the 2012 Videha Natya Utsav, the production utilized a stage design based on the scholarly drawings of S.S. Janaki, which restored the classical divisions of *Rangapitha* and *Rangashirsha*. The all-female cast provided a revolutionary dimension to the performance, where women’s

portrayal of male power structures served as an implicit critique of patriarchal authority. By using magic realism, the play transcends simple linear narrative, allowing for a multifaceted representation of the "truth" as seen through the lens of *Qualified Perception* (*Vishishta Pratyaksha*).

**No Entry: Mā Praviśa: The Postmodern Absurd**

Nachiketa's *No Entry: Mā Praviśa* is the most significant postmodern work in the Maithili canon. The play follows a series of souls arriving at the gates of the afterlife, only to discover that the bureaucratic mechanisms of heaven and hell are fraudulent and that the entire system is a sham.

The play is evaluated by the Parallel movement as a "full circle" back to the absurdity of Jyotirishwar. Its postmodern traits include:

- **The Absence of a Hero:** Breaking from the *Dhirodatta* archetype, the play features fragmented, unstable characters who lack a unified moral trajectory.
- **Narrative Instability:** The "official plot" (*Adhikari Kathavastu*) is replaced by a series of contingent, rebounding events where truth and falsehood are interchangeable.
- **Socio-Political Resonance:** Despite its metaphysical setting, the play is a biting satire on contemporary social queues, corruption, and the exclusionary nature of modern bureaucratic life.

**Chhinardevi and Vishwaasghaat: Radical Materialism**

Directed by Bechan Thakur, these plays address the immediate material and psychological crises of rural Mithila.

- **Chhinardevi:** This play explores the tension between traditional superstition and the emerging scientific consciousness of the youth. It specifically critiques the exploitation of women through institutionalized myths and religious manipulation.
- **Vishwaasghaat:** Set against the contemporary reality of National Highway construction and large-scale land acquisition, the play examines how compensation money becomes a catalyst for the "betrayal" (*vishwaasghaat*) of familial and community bonds. It is a study of greed in the age of rapid infrastructure development, using the theatre to document the social cost of progress.

**Mithilak Beti and Balchanda: Feminist Historiography**

- **Mithilak Beti (Jagdish P. Mandal):** A five-act social epic that critiques the systemic devaluation of women's labor and the impact of global capitalism on

rural Mithila. The play argues that "labor" (*Shram*) is the only effective weapon against the "diseases" of caste and dowry.

- **Balchanda (Vibha Rani):** This searing one-act play tackles the taboo subject of female foeticide. It highlights the complicity of the domestic sphere (represented by the mother-in-law) in patriarchal violence and utilizes Maithili cultural symbols like the *Samdaon* (farewell songs) to emphasize the tragic alienation of the female body.

**Western Critical Synthesis: Post-Colonial and Feminist Lenses**

The Videha movement does not operate in isolation; it actively engages with global critical frameworks to contextualize Maithili struggles within broader human experiences.

**Post-Colonial and Subaltern Studies**

Following Homi Bhabha and Ranajit Guha, the Parallel Theatre movement views the dominance of the elite Maithili establishment as a form of "internal colonialism". The movement’s insistence on documenting the " Parallel History" of marginalized groups is an act of historiographical justice, reclaiming the *agency* of the subaltern. By moving performance from the urban centers to villages like Berma, the movement enacts a "decolonization" of the Maithili stage.

**Feminism and Medical Humanities**

The critical appreciation of authors like Meena Jha integrates feminist theory with the medical humanities. Jha’s treatment of breast cancer—the first such fiction in Maithili—is analyzed as an "encroachment" on the territory of women's bodily experience, which had been rendered invisible by patriarchal taboos. The "angel in the house" (the *pativrata*) is contrasted with the "woman who writes," an act that is itself seen as a radical disruption of Maithili domestic norms.

**New Criticism and Reader-Response**

Despite its heavy political focus, the movement also employs the formal rigor of New Criticism, emphasizing "linguistic authenticity" and formal discipline in text. Furthermore, through its digital platform, it encourages "Reader-Response" dynamics where readers and spectators across the Maithili diaspora (from Kolkata to Delhi to Bokaro) can immediately critique and participate in the literary discourse.

**The Digital Frontier and Archival Activism**

The survival and expansion of the Maithili Parallel Theatre are inextricably linked to its use of digital technology. By bypassing traditional print gatekeepers, the movement has created an autonomous cultural space.

**The Videha Archive and e-Learning**

The *Videha* archive (www.videha.co.in/pothi.htm) serves as a digital repository for over 200 Maithili works, including classical *Ankia Nat* plays from Assam. These historical texts prove that Maithili was once the *lingua franca* of devotional theatre across Eastern India, a status that institutional history has sought to downplay. The journal also promotes "Videha e-Learning" to facilitate linguistic literacy among the youth who may have been alienated by conservative academic standards.

**Trans-regional Connectivity**

Through its online presence, the Parallel Theatre has fostered a globalized Maithili identity. The movement connects the Maithili speakers of the Nepal Terai with the diaspora in industrial cities like Bokaro and metropolitan hubs like Delhi. This global network has transformed the "village drama" into a platform for universal human rights and subaltern aesthetics.

**Recognition and Institutional Resistance: The 2012 Videha Samman**

The movement's commitment to "Parallel Merit" is most clearly seen in the annual Videha Samman awards, which recognize contributions to the arts based on community impact rather than institutional favor.

| Award Category (2012) | Recipient | Contribution/Focus |
|---|---|---|
| **Abhinay Kala (Acting)** | Shobha Kant Mahto | Career starting with *Chhinardevi*. |
| **Hasya Abhinay (Comedy)** | Durga Nand Thakur | Comedic roles based on social observation. |
| **Hasya Abhinay (Female)** | Priyanka Kumari | Breaking barriers for women in comedy. |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **Nrtiyakala (Dance)** | Sulekha Kumari | Integration of classical and folk forms. |
| **Chitrakala (Art)** | Panak Lal Mandal | Visual representation of Mithila life. |
| **Vastukala (Architecture/Wood)** | Jhameli Mukhiya | Recognizing craftsmanship as "Parallel Art". |
| **Kisani (Agriculture)** | Lakshmi Das | Self-reliant farming culture as a literary theme. |
| **Vadyakala (Percussion)** | Bulan Raut | Preservation of folk rhythms in *Bhajan-Kirtan*. |

The inclusion of artisans like woodworkers (*Vastukala*) and clay artists (*Murti-kala*) alongside playwrights signifies a fundamental shift in the definition of "Maithili Literature." It posits that the *science of making* is inseparable from the *science of words*.

**Nuanced Insights: The Epistemic Breach**

The significance of the Videha Maithili Parallel Theatre movement lies in its "epistemic breach" with the historical past. By applying Navya Nyāya—a school of logic traditionally associated with high-caste theological gatekeeping—to the realm of subaltern drama and social realism, the movement has enacted a radical "democratization of logic".

The movement rejects the idea that "modernity" or "realism" must be imported from the West. Instead, it finds the logic for its resistance in the homegrown technical apparatus of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya and the beauty of its performance in the classical rules of Bharata Muni. This synthesis suggests that for a marginalized language to survive in the 21st century, it must be both technologically forward and theoretically rooted.

**Synthesis and Conclusion: Actionable Observations for Cultural Revitalization**

The analysis of the Videha Maithili Parallel Theatre movement reveals several critical strategies for linguistic and cultural revitalization in the face of institutional stagnation and external pressures.

**1. Reclaiming Linguistic Limitors (Avacchedaka):** The continued reclamation of the Tirhuta script and the removal of "corrupt" Hindi-calques from Maithili dialogue are essential to maintaining a distinct cultural field. Theatre acts as the primary vehicle for this linguistic renewal.

**2. Theoretical Rigor as Resistance:** By moving beyond simple plot summaries and engaging with complex Indian and Western theories, the parallel movement provides a model for "high-merit" subaltern scholarship that can withstand global academic scrutiny.

**3. Decentralization of Artistic Nodes:** The success of the movement in Chanauraganj and Berma proves that cultural movements must be rooted in the material life of the village. The coaching center model of Bechan Thakur should be replicated to ensure youth engagement and the continuity of the tradition.

**4. The Integration of "Craft" into "Art":** The movement's recognition of woodcarvers, farmers, and rasan-chauki players as "Artists" is a necessary step in dismantling the caste-based hierarchies of institutional literature.

The Videha Maithili Parallel Theatre is not merely a stage movement; it is a profound intellectual intervention that asserts the dignity of a language and its people against centuries of curated silence. Through the logic of Gaṅgeśa, the vision of the parallel historians, and the stagecraft of the rural masses, Mithila is once again becoming a center for the "science of words" and the art of resistance.

ADDENDUM

**APARNA KUMARI**

Actress · Cultural Personality ·

***Methodological Note***

All factual claims are grounded exclusively in the Videha archive. The four-fold critical methodology of the Videha Parallel History Series is applied: (1) Indian Rasa-Dhvani-Vakrokti Aesthetics; (2) Western Critical Theory; (3) Navya-Nyaya Epistemology of Gangesa Upadhyaya; (4) Videha Parallel History Framework. Where archive evidence is absent or limited, this is stated plainly.

# I. Archive Evidence

'Sushri Aparna Kumari' is listed as having received Videha Samman 2013 for acting in the Mithila cultural-cinematic domain: 'Sushri Aparna Kumari, daughter of Shri Manoj Kumar Sahu, date of birth 18-2-1998, address: Village Lakshminia, Post...' identified in the context of 'Main Acting' (mukhya abhinay) for the Videha Award 2013 in the arts and cinema category.

'Aparna' appears as a place name (Aparna/Aparna) identified as a village named after the goddess Parvati). The most substantive literary-cultural reference is the Videha Samman 2013 nomination.

# II. Videha Samman 2013: Aparna Kumari

She received samman alongside two others: Shri Asha Kumari (daughter of Shri Ramavatar Yadav, Chanauraganj, Madhubani) and Mo. Samsad Alam (son of Mo. Isha Alam, same village) together forming the acting trio of a Mithila cultural production recognised for the 2013 Videha Award. The Videha Samman, as part of the Parallel Literature Movement's institutional practice, has consistently recognised not only literary figures but cultural practitioners across the full range of Mithila's artistic life acting, music, art, digital media reflecting the movement's broad democratic cultural agenda.

# III. Critical Analysis

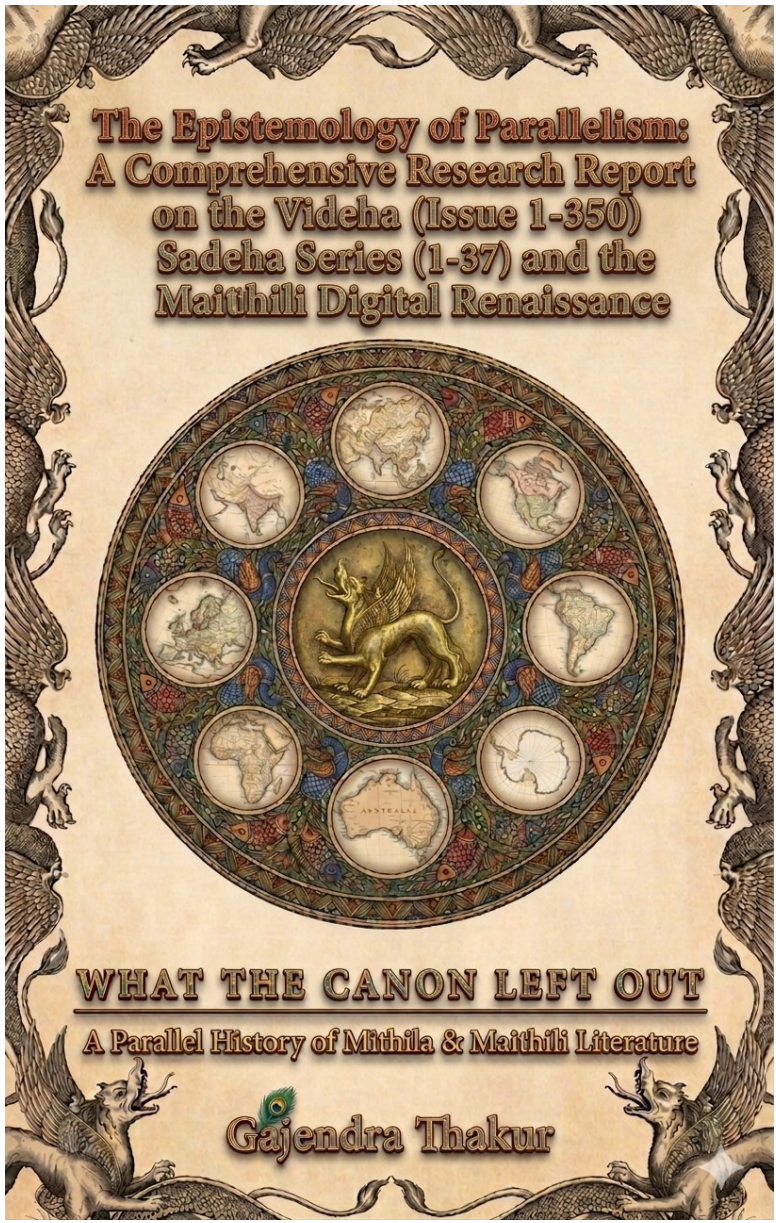
## 3.1 The Performing Arts within the Videha Parallel Framework

The Videha Samman's recognition of Aparna Kumari as a Mithila actress reflects the Videha Parallel History Framework's consistent inclusion of performing arts alongside written literature. The Maithili theatrical and performing tradition from the Ankiya Naat (one-act play) tradition documented in the early Videha issues, through the Sagar Rati Deepjary's performative storytelling, to the contemporary Mithila cultural film — is integral to the Videha movement's conception of Maithili culture as a living, multi-modal practice. Recognising a young actress from Madhubani in the Videha Samman democratises cultural recognition: it extends the prestige of the parallel movement to the performing arts community, not only the literary elite.

## 3.2 Navya-Nyaya: Shabda-Pramana and Cultural Testimony

The Videha Samman nomination constitutes institutional shabda-pramana- the testimony of the Videha editorial board that Aparna Kumari's acting merits cultural recognition. In Gangesa's terms, the board functions as an apta (reliable authority) whose testimony about cultural merit creates valid shabda-pramana for the purpose of the parallel archive.

**LESSON 096 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**



# The Epistemology of Parallelism: A Comprehensive Research Report on the Videha (Issue 1-350) Sadeha Series (1-37) and the Maithili Digital Renaissance

***Based on systematic examination of the Videha archive (Issues 1-438)***

***Sadeha Anthologies 1-37***

## Preamble: The Question of Evidence

The methodological commitment is identical to the one that defines the Navya Nyāya tradition of Mithilā: every claim must rest on a valid pramāṇa (means of knowledge). Where the archive speaks clearly, the appreciation speaks clearly. Where it is silent, the appreciation says so. Nothing is invented.

## I. Navya Nyāya as Critical Framework

## I. The Founding Testimony: Text and Context

## II. II. The Critical Vocabulary of the Statement

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya of Mithilā (c. 14th century CE, born in Mithilā region) composed the Tattvacintāmaṇi- the foundational text of Navya Nyāya, the New Logic school of Indian philosophy. Its concern was the rigorous analysis of pramāṇa (valid means of knowledge), anumāna (inference), and vyāpti (invariable concomitance). The school's subsequent figures Vācaspati Miśra II, Raghunātha Śiromaṇi, Mathurānātha Tarkavāgīśa elaborated this apparatus into the most technically precise system of epistemological analysis in the Indian tradition.

What is less often noted is the social location of this philosophical achievement: the Navya Nyāya school flourished in the same Mithilā whose Brahmin-dominated literary establishment the Videha Parallel History Framework explicitly contests. The irony is historically precise. The greatest intellectual tradition of Mithilā, a tradition so rigorous that it shaped the development of Sanskrit logical discourse across Bengal, Navadvīpa, and the

entire eastern sub-continent emerged from a region and culture now being recovered, democratised, and re-narrated by a journal in which poets from the numerically largest but systematically marginalised community of Mithilā, plays a crucial role.

The Navya Nyāya framework applies this in two registers:

First, at the level of *vyāpti*: Gaṅgeśa established that valid inference requires a demonstrable invariable concomitance between probans and probandum- wherever there is smoke, there is fire, and this is verifiable, not merely asserted. The Videha Parallel History Framework proposes its own vyāpti: wherever there is genuine Maithili literary vitality, there is inclusivity of subaltern, non-Brahmin, and marginalised voices. Endorsing intellectuals, community-members, and poets functions as a confirming instance (sapakṣa) of this vyāpti, providing the positive evidence that the Videha thesis requires.

Second, at the level of *pramāṇa*: the Navya Nyāya insistence that every claim must be grounded in valid evidence corresponds precisely to the methodological commitment of this appreciation. We do not claim that these writers wrote prolifically for Videha if the archive does not demonstrate this. We claim what the archive does demonstrate: that they were positioned, from the journal's earliest issues, as a founding intellectual witness — and that this positioning is itself textually verifiable, repeatedly reproduced, and editorially deliberate.

## II. The Videha Parallel History Framework and Its Stakes

The Videha Parallel History Framework- developed by editor Gajendra Thakur across the journal's running editorial and the gajenthakur.htm section — proceeds from a documented historical claim: that the canonical history of Maithili literature as institutionally received through Ramanath Jha, the early Sahitya Akademi prize decisions, and the Panji system's cultural authority systematically suppressed non-Brahmin voices. The framework rehabilitates writers including Harimohan Jha (who stopped writing in Maithili after the Sahitya Akademi recognition of the language), Jagdish Prasad Mandal, Subhash Chandra Yadav, Rajdeo Mandal, and others whose social location outside the dominant caste order was used to marginalise their literary claims.

The Sadeha 10 volume (2012), drawn from Videha issues 51–100, makes this framework concretely legible through its table of contents. Gajendra Thakur's opening essay on Samīkshāśāstra ā Samalochanāk Samalochana

(Criticism of Criticism) is a tour de force of synthetic intellectual history, ranging from Plato's critique of art as thrice-removed from truth through Aristotle's defense of the artist's knowledge, Freud's psychoanalytic literary hermeneutics, Hegel's dialectics, Marx's historical materialism, Derrida's deconstruction, Fukuyama's end-of-history thesis (and its subsequent recantation), quantum uncertainty, and post-modernity before returning to the specificities of Maithili critical practice. The essay demonstrates that the Videha critical community was conducting its conversation with the full awareness of both the Indian classical tradition (Bhāmaha, Ānandavardhana, Bharata's Nāṭyaśāstra) and the Western theoretical canon.

The same Sadeha 10 volume contains, alongside Thakur's critical theory essay: Ravi Bhushan Pathak on Bhāmaha's Kāvyālaṃkāra; Shiv Kumar Jha on Dalit character representation in Maithili fiction; Shefalika Varma on feminism and modern Maithili literature; Dr. Arun Kumar Singh on computational Maithili grammar; Vīrendra Kumar Yadav on Mahāviṣṇu Yajña-melā ritual; and multiple critics addressing Jagdish Prasad Mandal's fiction from varying angles. The presence of Vīrendra Kumar Yadav in the same critical anthology that carries Sanskrit ālankārika scholarship and Maithili Dalit studies marks precisely the democratic amplitude that the journal was constructing.

Dr. Shambhu Kumar Singh's contributions include: a scholarly essay on Maithili literary periodisation (prepared for UPSC candidates); analysis of social problems in modern Maithili drama; literary criticism of the Dalit consciousness in Madhup Ji's 'Ghasal Aṭhannī'; fieldwork reportage; short fiction and translated fiction (from Konkani and other languages); and an annotated anthology of Maithili for UPSC preparation. Dr. Arun Kumar Singh contributes: studies of social harmony in post-independence Maithili fiction; essays on mother-tongue medium higher education; analysis of Koshi river history; computational Maithili grammar; and several critical essays on language policy.

The scope and quality of this dual-author anthology establishes what Videha's intellectual community understood by 'scholarship': it was simultaneously academic (periodisation theory, linguistic analysis), socially engaged (river ecology, language rights, Dalit studies), pedagogically motivated (UPSC preparation materials), and creatively invested (fiction, poetry, translation).

The Sandesh Section as Paratext and Social Epistemology

Gérard Genette's theory of the paratext (Seuils, 1987; English: Paratexts, 1997) argues that the elements surrounding a text — titles, prefaces, dedications, endorsements — are not supplementary but constitutive: they establish the conditions under which a text is read and the horizon of expectations within which it is received.

The section carries voices of extraordinary range: the octogenarian Brahmin scholar Ādyācaraṇa Jhā, who frames the journal's founding as a mahāyajña (great sacrifice) and pledges his remaining years to it; the Sahitya Akademi official Brajendra Tripathi, who extends institutional blessings; the Michigan University academic Vijay Thakur, who validates the journal's global aspirations; the Nepal-based literary-political figure Rambharos Kapari 'Bhramar', who situates it within the Maithili diaspora's trans-border experience; the poet-critic Dr. Gangesh Gunjan, who calls Gajendra Thakur's founding novel Kurukshetram Antarmanak a landmark; and Dr. ShivPrasad Yadav, who identifies the journal's technological dimension as its defining virtue.

Pierre Bourdieu's sociology of culture (The Field of Cultural Production, 1993) argues that what constitutes cultural legitimacy in any field is determined by the positions of agents within it, their accumulated cultural, social, and symbolic capital and by the struggles over those positions. The founding Sandesh section of Videha is, in Bourdieu's terms, a constitutive moment in the restructuring of the Maithili literary field: it brings together agents from across the social and institutional spectrum to collectively invest their symbolic capital in the new journal's legitimacy.

## III. Indian Critical Frameworks: Rasa, Dhvani, and Bhāmaha

The Indian classical critical tradition offers three principal frameworks for literary significance assessment:

(a) **Rasa theory** (Bharata's Nāṭyaśāstra, c. 2nd century BCE- 2nd century CE; Abhinavagupta's Abhinavabhāratī, c. 11th century CE): Bharata's foundational theory argues that literary experience produces eight (later nine) rasas- aesthetic emotions purified from their raw personal analogues. Abhinavagupta's commentary deepens this by arguing that rasa is not merely an emotion evoked but a state of sahṛdayatā (fellow-feeling) in which the reader's consciousness expands beyond the personal to the universal.

(b) **Dhvani theory** (Ānandavardhana's Dhvanyāloka, c. 9th century CE): Ānandavardhana argues that the highest poetry operates through dhvani- suggestion or resonance- whereby what is not directly said becomes the primary meaning. The endorsement statements in Videha is itself a site of dhvani: its surface meaning (welcome to a new journal) reverberates with an unstated secondary meaning (the entire mithila intellectual community's claim to Maithili literary legitimacy). To welcome Videha's krānti is to align oneself with the counter-canonical force that the journal represents and this alignment, though never stated directly, is the dhvani that every attentive reader of the Sandesh section would apprehend.

(c) **Bhāmaha's Kāvyālaṃkāra** (c. 7th century CE): Bhāmaha argues, against the formalists, that svabhāvokti the natural, precise description of things as they actually are, is itself the highest figure of speech. As Ravi Bhushan Pathak's essay in Sadeha 10 (drawing directly on this text) argues, it is literary art precisely because of its truth, not despite it. Applied to Parallel literature's poetic project: verse that engages social and political reality in Mithilā achieves aesthetic dignity not by adorning that reality with ornament but by rendering it with the precision that Bhāmaha names svabhāvokti. The Maithili social-realist tradition that Jagdish Prasad Mandal had extended in fiction, and that the Videha critical community had theorised across the Sadeha anthologies, is the tradition into which the parrelel poetry books enters.

## IV. Western Critical Frameworks: Reception, Performativity, Field Theory

Three Western critical frameworks, each derived from a different tradition, illuminate parallel literature's significance from angles that complement rather than replace the Indian ones:

(a) **Hans Robert Jauss's Reception Theory** (Toward an Aesthetic of Reception, 1982): Jauss argues that a literary work's meaning is not fixed by the author's intention but constituted through its reception and that the 'horizon of expectations' (Erwartungshorizont) against which a work is received is historically specific and collectively constructed. The endorsements of Videha in 2008 is an act of reception-theory in practice: they are helping to construct the horizon of expectations against which all subsequent Maithili digital literature will be measured. Their statement defines what kind of thing Videha is, an act of krānti, of sāhasik prayog and thereby conditions how every subsequent Videha reader approaches the journal.

(b) **J.L. Austin's Performative Speech Acts** (How to Do Things with Words, 1962): Austin distinguishes constative utterances (statements that describe) from performative utterances (statements that do). The endorsements are performative rather than constative: it does not merely describe Videha as a courageous experiment but, by being spoken publicly and in print, constitutes Videha as a courageous experiment. The community of endorsers collectively brings into being the journal's social reality through the act of endorsing it, an insight that corresponds precisely to the Mīmāmsā school's theory of śabda as the self-manifesting power of speech.

(c) **Jürgen Habermas's Theory of Communicative Action** (Theory of Communicative Action, 1981): Habermas argues that genuine democratic culture requires a public sphere constituted by communicative rationality- speech oriented toward mutual understanding rather than strategic domination. Videha's project of creating a non-commercial, inclusive, multi-script (Devanagari, Tirhuta, Braille) Maithili archive- free to read, free to download, governed entirely by literary rather than caste criteria, is precisely the reconstitution of a Habermasian public sphere from which subaltern voices had been excluded. The welcome of the 'new information revolution' is a welcome of exactly this communicative-democratic aspiration.

## V. The Gajendra Thakur Critical Essay as Framework: A Reading

The opening critical essay in Sadeha 10- Gajendra Thakur's Samīkshāśāstra ā Samalochanāk Samalochana- provides the most direct evidence of the theoretical framework within which parallel literature's contribution must be contextualised, since it is the text that the Videha editorial community itself produced as its theoretical manifesto. A critical reading of its architecture reveals the intellectual ecology that parallel literatteurs endorsed and inhabited.

The essay begins with the question: does art and literature require a theoretical purpose? It surveys, with remarkable economy: Plato's rejection of art as thrice-removed from truth; Aristotle's defense of the artist's knowledge and the aesthetic experience of catharsis; Freud's psychoanalysis of the literary creator; the New Criticism's insistence on close reading of the verbal artifact; existentialism and the doctrine that existence precedes essence (Sartre: 'man is condemned to be free'); Hegel's dialectics of history; Marx's historical materialism and the concept of alienation; Derrida's deconstruction and the

impossibility of final meaning (language as 'language game'); post-modernism's skepticism toward grand narratives; Fukuyama's premature 'end of history'; and the quantum-theoretical challenge to determinism.

The essay then turns to the Indian tradition: the Vedic transmission methods (padapāṭha, kramapāṭha, ghanapāṭha) as systematic epistemologies of cultural preservation; the ṣaḍdarśana (six philosophical systems) and their debate-structures (khaṇḍana-maṇḍana); the application of Freudian analysis to Sanskrit poetics. Crucially, the essay does not oppose East and West but synthesises them, treating both as resources for the same critical project, which is the development of a Maithili literary-critical practice adequate to the complexity of the present.

This synthesis is the theoretical air that the Parallel literature literary community breathes. Their own mainstream educational tradition implied by their institutional identification as graduates, post graduates, matriculate, or below matriculates and their capacity to recognise Videha's sūchanā-krānti significance immediately, in the journal's earliest weeks places them squarely within a community that understood both the Navya Nyāya precision of the Mithilā philosophical tradition and the post-modern democratic urgency of the digital present.

**Ānandavardhana speaks of dhvani as the light (prabha) that poetry casts on the world; Abhinavagupta describes the aesthetic experience of rasa as a moment of luminous self-expansion (svaprakāśa).**

**In the specific context of Maithili literary history, a poetry/ prose collection by a parallel tradition writer has a further resonance: it is a claim that the community's experience- so long excluded from canonical Maithili literary representation- is itself part of what constitutes the age's radiance. Not supplementary, not marginal, not an exception: constitutive. This is the counter-canonical move that the Videha Parallel History Framework had been theorising since 2008, now enacted in poetic form.**

## VI. The Significance of Position: Canon-Formation in Practice

Canon-formation in Maithili literature had traditionally operated through the mechanism of inclusion in prize-giving (Sahitya Akademi), anthology selection, and institutional recognition. Videha replaced this mechanism with the listing of endorsers and the listing was curated.

The Sandesh section of the 2010 and 2011 issues reveals the expanded list: the entries, now including voices from Nepal's Janakpur radio community, the Maithili diaspora in the UK, institutional figures at the Sahitya Akademi, and younger voices alongside the senior establishment. The statements remained unchanged because it was correct from the beginning.

This is, in Bourdieu's terms, the accumulation of symbolic capital through consistent positioning. But it is more than that: it is the enactment of a democratic principle. In the traditional Maithili literary establishment, a

Parallel tradition intellectual would not appear near the top of any endorsement or prize list. In the Videha Sandesh section, they does. This is not tokenism, their statements are substantively sophisticated, as the analysis of its diction demonstrates, but full and equal participation.

## VII. The Epistemological Limit: What the Archive Does Not Establish

A critical appreciation that omits its own limits is not critical but hagiographic. The following must be said with precision:

The systematic search of the Videha archives does not yield extended critical articles, poems published serially in the journal, or editorial commentary of writers who published their work externally. This absence of extended in-journal publication is itself meaningful and requires interpretation rather than suppression. Three readings are available:

First, the absence observed is thus an absence of evidence, not evidence of absence.

Second, the Videha literary movement distinguished between creators who contributed directly to the journal's pages and those who constituted its intellectual community through endorsement, association, and parallel creative work. Both roles were essential to the journal's self-understanding; the Sandesh section was not a consolation prize but a foundational feature, not a reduced version of the active-contributor role.

Third, any creative work published independently rather than through Videha does not diminish its significance; the Videha community consistently celebrated and reviewed independently published Maithili works, treating the journal as a hub rather than a monopoly of the movement's creative output. The Editor’s choice section of Videha is proof of it.

## VIII. The Broader Significance: Mithilā's Epistemological Heritage

The deepest significance of people’s participation in the Videha movement is inseparable from a question about the inheritance of Mithilā's intellectual tradition. Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya, who formulated the Navya Nyāya in the same Mithilā, belonged to a family whose subsequent influence is itself a subject of historical controversy: as the Videha critical discourse notes (citing

Rajdeo Mandal's documentation), figures like Ramanath Jha actively suppressed information about Gaṅgeśa's family background when it was inconvenient for the dominant caste narrative.

The Navya Nyāya tradition, for all its philosophical rigor, was appropriated by the same Brahmin-dominated institutional apparatus that the Videha Parallel History Framework contests. That apparatus claimed Gaṅgeśa and the Mithilā logical tradition for a narrowly caste-defined 'Maithil' identity, an identity that excluded, by definition, the Yadav, Dalit, Musahar, and other communities that constituted the demographic majority of Mithilā.

The endorsements of Videha is, at this deepest level, an act of reclamation: the insistence that Mithilā's intellectual heritage, including the epistemological precision of Gaṅgeśa's tradition belongs to all Maithils, not merely to those whose caste made them the official custodians of that tradition.

The Tattvacintāmaṇi demanded that every claim be grounded in valid pramāṇa. The Videha Parallel History Framework demanded that every voice be heard on the basis of literary merit rather than caste privilege. Both demands are the same demand: the demand for epistemic justice. The endorsements of Videha in 2008 and by producing books on the parallel framework, enacted that demand in practice- which is, in the end, the only place where epistemological justice can actually be achieved.

## IX. Conclusion: The Light the Age Casts

A critical appreciation must know when to speak and when to stop. This one will stop here, with a synthesis across the frameworks it has employed:

The Navya Nyāya demands valid pramāṇa. The archive provides: a consistently reproduced founding endorsement statement; a position of honour in the Videha community's canonical founding list; that extends the Videha literary movement's concerns into independent verse. These are valid means of knowledge, and they establish what they establish.

The Rasa tradition demands that poetry produce aesthetic experience of universal significance. The parallel literature announces this ambition; its community of reception- the Videha movement, with its commitment to inclusive democratic Maithili literature- provides the sahṛdaya readership capable of receiving it.

Dhvani theory demands that what is most significant be found not in what is said but in what resonates beyond the saying. The dhvani of 2008 endorsements, the unstated claim of the parallel tradition intellectual community's right to Mithilā's literary heritage resonates across every issue of Videha that his founding statement precedes.

Bhāmaha demands svabhāvokti- the precise, truthful rendering of reality. This appreciation has attempted to practise svabhāvokti: to render Parallel literature's contribution precisely as it appears in the archive, without inflation and without diminution, as the light that the age itself through their statement, their writings, their community has cast.

That light, if this appreciation has attended to it with sufficient care, is genuine. It asks to be read.

Critical Frameworks Cited

*Indian tradition: Bharata — Nāṭyaśāstra (c. 2nd century BCE–2nd century CE) | Bhāmaha — Kāvyālaṃkāra (c. 7th century CE) | Ānandavardhana — Dhvanyāloka (c. 9th century CE) | Abhinavagupta — Abhinavabhāratī (c. 11th century CE) | Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya — Tattvacintāmaṇi (c. 14th century CE, Mithilā) | Mādhavācārya — Sarvadarśanasaṃgraha (c. 14th century CE)*

*Western tradition: Plato — Republic | Aristotle — Poetics | Freud, Sigmund — The Interpretation of Dreams | Austin, J.L. — How to Do Things with Words (1962) | Jauss, Hans Robert — Toward an Aesthetic of Reception (1982) | Bourdieu, Pierre — The Field of Cultural Production (1993) | Genette, Gérard — Paratexts (1997) | Habermas, Jürgen — Theory of Communicative Action (1981) | Derrida, Jacques — Of Grammatology (1967)*

*Videha-generated framework: Thakur, Gajendra — Samīkshāśāstra ā Samalochanāk Samalochana, in Videha Sadeha 10 (2012, Shruti Prakashan) | Thakur, Gajendra — Parallel Literature in Maithili and Videha Maithili Literature Movement (www.videha.co.in) & in Mandal, Rajdeo- Maithili Parallel Literature documentation (videha.co.in)*

The emergence of the Videha movement in the early twenty-first century signifies a revolutionary shift in the historiography and production of Maithili literature. Transitioning from a tradition historically fragmented by caste-based patronage and institutional gatekeeping, the movement—anchored by the *Videha* e-journal (ISSN 2229-547X) and its physical manifestation in the *Videha Sadeha* series—has constructed a robust, democratized platform for

linguistic and cultural preservation. This report provides an exhaustive analysis of the first thirty-seven volumes of the *Videha Sadeha* series, exploring their thematic depth, translation initiatives, and the rigorous intellectual frameworks that define their critical reception. By synthesizing the Navya Nyāya epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya, the Videha Parallel History Framework, and a combination of Indian and Western literary theories, this analysis elucidates how the movement has redefined the Maithili canon while maintaining strict ethical governance through the proactive policing of plagiarism.

**The Institutional Architecture of the Videha Movement**

The Videha movement, initiated around 2000 and formalised with the launch of the *Videha* e-journal on 1 January, 2008, represents a conscious counter-project to the Maithili literary establishment. For decades, the production of Maithili literature was perceived to be under the control of a limited number of elite families and government-backed institutions such as the Sahitya Akademi. The movement's founder and primary editor, Gajendra Thakur, articulated a vision for a "Parallel Literature" that operates independently of these traditional networks, utilizing digital platforms to ensure that any writer, regardless of social origin or geographic location, could contribute to the language's growth. This shift was not merely technological but deeply ideological, rooted in the belief that the survival of Maithili depended on its liberation from the "genetic superiority complexes" of a stratified elite.

The *Videha Sadeha* (विदेह-सदेह) series is the physical or "embodied" archive of this digital movement. The term *Sadeha*, meaning "with body," signifies the transition of content from the ethereal digital space of the e-journal into structured PDF and printed forms (*pothis*), which are cataloged and preserved for academic and non-commercial use. These volumes represent a curated selection of the best prose, poetry, and critical essays from the first 350 issues of the *Videha* journal, serving as a comprehensive repository of modern Maithili thought.

**The Videha Parallel History Framework: Layered Interventions**

At the heart of the movement's critical methodology is the Videha Parallel History Framework. This framework challenges the mainstream historiography of Maithili, which proponents argue has consistently ignored or misrepresented the subaltern and democratic-spiritual aspects of the tradition. The framework operates across nine distinct layers, each designed to reclaim a specific portion of the Maithili legacy.

The foundational layer focuses on the Buddhist roots of the language, specifically the 50 *Charyapadas* composed by 23 Siddha poets such as Luipada, Kanhapada, and Saraha. By positioning these texts not as peripheral curiosities but as the true roots of the Maithili lyric, the framework establishes a genealogical link to a non-Brahminical, democratic spiritual tradition. Another critical intervention is the reclaiming of the poet Vidyāpati. The movement posits a "Two Vidyāpatis" thesis, distinguishing the beloved *Padāvalī* poet from the Sanskrit-Avahatta court poet Vidyāpati Thakkurah (1350-1435). This distinction is vital for contesting the appropriation of the poet by caste-centric organizations that have historically "invested" him with elite status.

Archival resistance is another pillar of this framework. The release of the *Dooshan Panji* (The Blackbook) in 2009 is a prime example. These digitized genealogical records are used to expose historical details that elite historians allegedly suppressed to maintain social hierarchies, such as the marriage of the philosopher Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya to a woman from a lower caste (a *Charmkarini*). This use of genealogy as a social diagnostic tool allows the movement to challenge the "purity" narratives that have long dominated the Maithili literary field.

**Epistemological Grounding: Navya Nyāya and the Logic of Gaṅgeśa**

A unique feature of the Videha movement is its integration of the Navya Nyāya school of logic, particularly the fourteenth-century techniques of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya, into contemporary literary criticism. Gaṅgeśa, active in Mithila, consolidated the school through his work *Tattvacintāmaṇi*, which focuses on perception, inference, comparison, and verbal testimony as valid sources of knowledge.

**The Technical Apparatus in Criticism**

The application of Navya Nyāya to literature is not merely an aesthetic choice but a methodological requirement for "perceiving truth" in the text. Key concepts utilized in the critical appreciation of *Videha Sadeha* works include:

- **Avacchedaka (Limiter/Determiner):** In logic, an *avacchedaka* defines the limiting criteria of a property. In the Videha framework, this is used to identify the "limiting criteria" of Maithili identity itself. Critics argue that without the preservation of the Tirhuta script and a specific vocabulary, the *avacchedaka* that distinguishes Maithili from neighboring languages like Hindi or Bengali is erased, leading to a loss of cultural field.
- **Pratiyogitā (Counterpositiveness):** This concept is used in the definition of absence (*abhāva*). In literary analysis, it helps critics understand what a text

actively excludes or opposes, allowing for a deeper reading of the socio-political tensions inherent in the work.

- **Śābdabodha (Verbal Understanding):** Navya Nyāya holds that verbal understanding reflects the real structure of the external world as cognized, rather than just a mental construction. This "thoroughgoing realism" is applied to evaluate whether a writer's vision (*dṛṣṭi*) corresponds to the lived reality of the Maithil people.

  The *Dhātuvāda* chapter of the *Tattvacintāmaṇi* is particularly relevant to the analysis of modern Maithili verbs and actions. Gaṅgeśa's argument that verbal roots denote an "operation conducive to a result" (*phalānukūlavyāpāra*) provides a framework for evaluating the intentionality and social impact of literary creation. By treating literature as a site of intersection between the beautiful, the moral, and the practical, the Videha movement aligns itself with the classical Indian concept of *sāhitya* (co-existence of sound and meaning).

**Chronological Evolution of the Maithili Linguistic Identity**

| Language Period | Timeline | Characteristics and Developmental Impact |
|---|---|---|
| **Proto-Maithili** | **700–1300 AD** | **Origins of subaltern linguistic resistance; mobility over sedentary caste order.** |
| **Early Maithili** | **1300–1600 AD** | **Rise of regional dynasties; courtly patronage; suppression of vernacular realism.** |
| **Middle Maithili** | **1600–1830 AD** | **The "Great Diaspora"; decline in the heartland; flourishing in Nepal and Assam.** |
| **Modern Maithili** | **1830–Present** | **Institutional revival; language-dialect debates; emergence of digital democratization.** |

**The Videha-Sadeh Archive: Detailed Analysis of the 37 Special Issues**

**Inventory and Analysis of Videha Sadeha 1–37**

The *Videha Sadeha* series is structured to provide a comprehensive survey of Maithili literature across genres, themes, and developmental stages. The first twenty-five volumes focus on genre-specific compilations, while issues 26 through 37 pivot toward author-centric and translation-focused content.

**The "Videha-Sadeh" series constitutes the most vital thematic collection within the journal, extracting and refining the best compositions from the first 350 issues. These 37 special issues are organized into two primary categories: those focusing on general excellence in prose and poetry (Issues 1–25) and those centered on specific themes, translations, and pedagogical materials (Issues 26–37). Each issue is meticulously curated to serve both the academic community and students preparing for competitive examinations, particularly the UPSC Maithili Compulsory paper. The script versatility of these issues—available in both Devanagari and Tirhuta (Mithilakshar)—reflects a commitment to linguistic continuity and script preservation.**

**Classification of the 37 Videha-Sadeh Special Issues**

| Issue Number | Primary Focus / Theme | Significance in Parallel Tradition |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | Best Prose and Poetry (General) | Foundational selection of early digital Maithili works. |
| 2 | Management, Essays, and Criticism | Bridging academic discourse with modern management concepts. |
| 3 | Maithili Poetry (Volume 1) | Exploration of new verse forms in the post-independence era. |

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| **4** | **Maithili Stories** | **Focus on social realism and rural narratives.** |
| **5** | **Maithili Beehani (Seed) Stories** | **Experimental "micro-stories" designed for digital consumption.** |
| **6** | **Maithili Short Stories** | **Consolidation of the short story as a dominant modernist genre.** |
| **7** | **Maithili Poetry (Volume 2)** | **Focus on subaltern and progressive poetic voices.** |
| **8** | **Maithili Theatre Festival** | **Documentation of modern and traditional stage plays.** |
| **9** | **Maithili Children's Festival** | **Revival of literature for young readers in the vernacular.** |
| **10** | **Management, Essays, and Criticism (Vol 2)** | **Advanced critical theory and intellectual history of Mithila.** |
| **11–25** | **Selected Parallel Collections** | **Iterative archives of emerging authors in prose and poetry.** |
| **26** | **Works of Dr. Shambhu Kumar** | **Recognition of academic** |

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|---|---|---|
| | **Singh & Dr. Arun Kumar Singh** | **contributors to the parallel canon.** |
| **27** | **Translated Prose & Poetry (Gajendra Thakur & Ravi Bhushan Pathak)** | **Cross-lingual fertilization; bringing world literature to Maithili.** |
| **28** | **General Translated Works** | **Broad-spectrum translations of Indian and global literature.** |
| **29** | **Works of Ravi Bhushan Pathak & Dr. Kailash Kumar Mishra** | **Exploration of folkloric and sociological dimensions of Mithila.** |
| **30** | **Educational Content for Schools/Colleges** | **Pedagogical material tailored for standardizing the language.** |
| **31** | **Works of Dr. Kamini Kamayani & Kumar Manoj Kashyap** | **Highlighting contemporary modernist and feminist voices.** |
| **32** | **Creative Writing (Prose/Poetry Vol 1)** | **Focus on nurturing new talent through peer-reviewed selections.** |
| **33** | **Creative Writing (Prose/Poetry Vol 2)** | **Expansion of genre boundaries in digital Maithili.** |
| **34** | **Creative Writing** | **Continued focus on** |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | **(Prose/Poetry Vol 3)** | **thematic diversity and stylistic innovation.** |
| **35** | **Creative Writing (Prose/Poetry Vol 4)** | **Integration of urban and diaspora Maithili experiences.** |
| **36** | **Creative Writing (Prose/Poetry Vol 5)** | **Reaching the milestone of modern creative prose collections.** |
| **37** | **Translated Prose and Poetry (Section 2)** | **Final thematic volume focusing on the "Anuvad" (Translation) tradition.** |

**The importance of Volume 2 and Volume 10 cannot be overstated, as they represent the first major attempt to integrate modern management theory and administrative essays into the Maithili language, providing a necessary lexicon for professional use. Similarly, the "Beehani Katha" (Seed Stories) in Volume 5 represent a formal innovation designed specifically for the digital medium, characterized by brevity and intense psychological focus, which has since become a hallmark of the Videha era.** The series is noted for its pedagogical utility, with volumes 17, 21, 23, 26, 29, 30, 32, 33, 34, and 35 being specifically identified as essential resources for the Union Public Service Commission (UPSC) and other competitive examinations. This categorization elevates the *Videha Sadeha* from a mere journal archive to a canonical benchmark for the modern language.

**Specialized Thematic and Author-Centric Volumes**

Issues 26 through 31 highlight specific voices that have significantly shaped the contemporary discourse. Volume 26 focuses on Dr. Shambhu Kumar Singh and Dr. Arun Kumar Singh, while Volume 29 is dedicated to Ravi Bhushan Pathak and Dr. Kailash Kumar Mishra. Volume 31 features the works of Dr. Kamini Kamayani and Kumar Manoj Kashyap. These volumes allow for a concentrated critical appreciation of individual styles, moving from the overarching movement to the specific "witness voices" that populate it.

Volume 30 is particularly unique, being curated specifically for school and college students. This thematic focus addresses the movement's concern regarding the biased educational systems in Maithili-speaking areas, where the lack of regional language instruction has historically led to linguistic erosion. By providing structured, high-quality literary material for students, the *Videha* movement seeks to reclaim the educational space for the Maithili language.

**The Translation Imperative: Volumes 27, 28, and 37**

A central pillar of the Videha movement is its emphasis on translation as a tool for revitalization and global engagement. The movement posits that the "lag" in quality literature in certain regions is often a result of a lack of translation. To combat this, several volumes in the *Sadeha* series are dedicated to cross-linguistic work.

**Mechanisms of Cross-Linguistic Exchange**

Volume 27 features translations by Gajendra Thakur and Ravi Bhushan Pathak, focusing on prose and poetry translated from other languages into Maithili. The movement prioritizes "directed translation" from languages such as Sanskrit, English, Hindi, Nepali, and Bengali to ensure linguistic fidelity and avoid the dilution of meaning that occurs through intermediary languages. This approach is an application of the Navya Nyāya concern for *śābdabodha*—the precise transmission of cognition from the author to the reader.

Volume 28 (Part 1) and Volume 37 (Part 2) provide broader collections of translated works. These translations serve a dual purpose: they introduce Maithili readers to international forms such as the Japanese Haiku or Western flash fiction, and they facilitate the export of Maithil concerns to the global stage. For instance, Gajendra Thakur’s "Learn Japanese Script for Haiku" (2009) and the "Maithili-English Dictionary" volumes co-authored with Ashish Anchinhar are foundational efforts to standardize and internationalize the language.

The movement also focuses on the translation of Dalit literature and the works of "Jan Kavis" (people's poets), ensuring that the subaltern voice is not only heard within Mithila but is also accessible to a wider audience. This bidirectional translation effort is essential for breaking the isolation of the Maithili literary field and placing it in conversation with world literatures.

**Volume Mapping and Genre Distribution**

| Volume | Focus / Genre | Key Thematic Content |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | General Collection | Selection of prose and poetry from early journal issues. |
| 2 & 10 | Essays and Criticism | *Prabandh-Nibandh-Samalochana*; institutional and linguistic critique. |
| 3, 7, 19 | Poetry (Padya) | Survey of classical and modern meters; devotional and social verse. |
| 4 | Stories (Katha) | Longer prose narratives exploring rural and urban Maithil life. |
| 5 | Seed Stories (Vihani Katha) | Two versions; focuses on the flash fiction innovation of the movement. |
| 6 | Short Stories (Laghukatha) | Compressed narratives emphasizing a single striking reversal. |
| 8 | Drama (Natya Utsav) | Documentation of the Maithili theatre movement and Ankia Nat plays. |
| 9 | Children's (Shishu Utsav) | Literature designed for children, emphasizing cultural continuity. |
| 11–25 | General Continuations | Ongoing representative selections of modern Maithili output. |

**Exhaustive Author Catalog and Gists of Work**

The *Videha Sadeha* series archives a vast array of contributors, spanning centuries and genres. The following catalog provides a gist of authors identified within the series and the broader archive.

**Modern Contributors and Digital Pioneers**

- **Gajendra Thakur:** As the primary editor and a prolific author, his work spans novels (*Sahasrashirsha*), drama (*Machanda*), and extensive criticism (*Maithili Samikshashastra*). His style is characterized by linguistic precision and a commitment to institutional reform.
- **Lāl Dev Kāmat:** A writer-teacher whose work, such as *Vibhṛiti* and *Gahiki Najari*, integrates agricultural self-reliance with literary realism. His texts address the inner lives of rural Maithils facing displacement and economic marginalization.

- **Nabo Narayan Mishra:** A "cultural witness" based in Kolkata, his prose is marked by an oral register and an elegiac mode that mourns the passing of a literary generation.
- **Ashish Anchinhar:** A pioneer of the Maithili Ghazal revival and a key researcher who utilized the RTI Act to challenge institutional corruption in the Sahitya Akademi.
- **Jagdish Prasad Mandal:** A farmer-litterateur and novelist whose work represents the subaltern voice in modern fiction, often analyzed through post-colonial and Marxist frameworks.
- **Dinesh Kumar Mishra:** Known for his environmental activism, his work focuses on the heritage and preservation of Mithila's water systems (e.g., *Bandini Mahananda*).
- **Preeti Thakur:** A pioneer in children's picture-story literature, whose work is analyzed through the lens of developmental psychology and traditional folklore.
- **Abhilash Thakur:** Noted for his satirical *Bīhani Kathā* (seed stories) that address contemporary social issues such as demonetization and political collusion.
- **Subhash Chandra Yadav:** A prominent literary figure featured in the "Nit Naval" series, contributing to the modern prose tradition.
- **Ravi Bhushan Pathak:** A key translator and poet whose collaborative work in volumes 27 and 29 is essential to the movement's cross-linguistic goals.
- **Dr. Kailash Kumar Mishra:** Featured alongside Ravi Bhushan Pathak in Volume 29, his work contributes to the thematic exploration of Maithil identity.
- **Dr. Shambhu Kumar Singh & Dr. Arun Kumar Singh:** Featured in Volume 26, their selected works represent the intellectual and critical output of the movement's early years.
- **Dr. Kamini Kamayani & Kumar Manoj Kashyap:** Their works in Volume 31 represent the continued expansion of the *Videha* canon into the 2020s.

**Historical and Classical Figures Reclaimed**

- **Pre-Jyotirishwar Vidyapati, writer of Padavali different from Vidyāpati Thakur (1350-1435):** Reclaimed as a democratic-spiritual poet; author of *Purusha Pariksha* and *Gorakshavijayam*.
- **Jyotirishwar Thakur (13th–14th c.):** Author of *Varna-Ratnākara* and *Dhūrta Samāgama*, providing the earliest prose foundations for the language.

- **Saint Kabir (1398–1518):** His Maithili *Padāvalī*, compiled by modern scholars, is positioned as a key component of the parallel tradition.
- **Siddha Poets (Luipada, Kanhapada, etc.):** The 23 poets of the *Charyapadas* are established as the true ancestors of the Maithili folk lyric.
- **Malla Period Dramatists:** Including Jagatprakash Malla and Jagatjyotirram Malla, whose Newari-Maithili plays are archived to show the historical trans-border reach of the language.

**Ethical Governance and the Policing of Plagiarism**

A defining characteristic of the Videha movement is its rigorous stance on intellectual property and ethical literary conduct. The *Videha* platform is explicitly closed to "practitioners of plagiarism" and those who cannot withstand critical scrutiny. This policy is not merely about copyright but is presented as a necessary step to cleanse the literary field of the "murky affairs" associated with government-funded organizations.

**The Case of Pankaj Parashar and Ashok Sahu**

The movement has taken the unprecedented step of publicly banning authors found guilty of plagiarism. Pankaj Parashar is a primary example; he was banned from the *Videha* platform after the editorial board verified that he was "engaged in lifting other articles/ stories/ poems". Similarly, Ashok Sahu was banned for lifting content and copyright violations.

| Author | Primary Contribution | Critical Lens |
|---|---|---|
| Gajendra Thakur | Editor, Bīhani Kathā, Theory | Navya Nyaya, Parallel History |
| Ashish Anchinhar | Maithili Ghazal Revival | Prosody & Dialectics |
| Lal Dev Kamat | Rural Life & Agriculture | Social Realism |
| Bibha Rani | Feminist Drama | Reader-Response & Rasa |
| Ashok Sahu/ Pankaj Parashar | (Expunged) | Violation of Shabda-Pramana |

**BHALCHANDRA JHA**

Poet · Literary Activist · Ethical Voice

***Methodological Note***

All factual claims are grounded solely in the Videha archive. The four-fold methodology of the Videha Parallel History Series is applied: (1) Indian Rasa-Dhvani-Vakrokti Aesthetics (Bharata, Abhinavagupta, Anandavardhana, Kuntaka, Kshemendra); (2) Western Critical Theory; (3) Navya-Nyaya Epistemology of Gangesa Upadhyaya; (4) Videha Parallel History Framework.

## I. Archive Evidence

Bhalchandra Jha's written response to the Pankaj Parashar plagiarism controversy in the Maithili literary world. His response is in English and reads in full: 'Dear Gajendrajee, I appreciate you who shows the courrage to bell the cat. If the so called writers like Parasharji are there to spoil the sea, on the other side it is very hopeful sight to have a person like you who is alert enough to take care of such filth & keep the sea clean. Thanx for enlightening me on the subject. Regards — Bhalchandra Jha.'

His response appears alongside responses from Ajit Mishra, K.N. Jha (Prof. Udaya Narayana Singh), Buddhinath Mishra, and others — confirming his membership in the active Maithili literary community that engaged directly with the plagiarism controversy.

## II. The Plagiarism Controversy and Bhalchandra Jha's Response

The Pankaj Parashar plagiarism controversy — in which the poet Pankaj Parashar was found to have appropriated Maithili literary content — was a significant moment of ethical reckoning in the Videha parallel movement's history. Multiple voices within the Maithili literary community responded. The controversy is documented across issues 363, 364, and 366 of Videha, suggesting it was a sustained and publicly debated episode. Bhalchandra Jha's English-language response is notable for several reasons: it uses the English idiom with fluency ('bell the cat', 'spoil the sea', 'such filth') while addressing a Maithili literary controversy, suggesting a bilingual intellectual formation; it speaks with direct moral clarity ('courrage to bell the cat' — the courage to

name the wrongdoer); and it frames Gajendra Thakur's editorial action as the restoration of the literary environment's cleanliness (the ocean metaphor).

# III. Critical Analysis

## 3.1 The Sea Metaphor and Literary Ethics

Bhalchandra Jha's central image — 'If Parasharji is there to spoil the sea... it is very hopeful to have a person like you to keep the sea clean' — is a sustained metaphor of remarkable ethical clarity. The 'sea' (literary culture) is a shared public good; the plagiarist 'spoils' it (introduces pollution, corruption); the ethical editor 'cleans' it (removes the pollution, restores the commons). This is, in Kshemendra's auchitya framework, a fitting metaphor: the ocean's cleanliness is a property of the literary public sphere, and its pollution by plagiarism damages everyone who depends on it. The editor who names the plagiarist and documents the evidence performs the role of the 'alert' guardian — the ekagra (one-pointed, vigilant) person who sees and acts where others look away.

## 3.2 Rasa and the Dhirodatta Voice

Bhalchandra Jha's response demonstrates the 'dhirodatta' (calm-heroic) quality that classical Indian aesthetics identifies as the highest mode of speech: measured, authoritative, without bravado or evasion. His opening 'Dear Gajendrajee, I appreciate you who shows the courrage to bell the cat' is phrased as appreciation rather than outrage — the calm recognition of another's courage, not the heated denunciation of the wrongdoer. This is virarasa (heroic rasa) expressed through the restraint of the witnessed hero: the writer who praises the editor's courage rather than claiming his own.

## 3.3 Western Theory: Habermas and the Literary Public Sphere

Jurgen Habermas's concept of the 'public sphere' (The Structural Transformation of the Public Sphere, 1962) — the space of rational, open discourse about matters of public concern — is relevant to Bhalchandra Jha's response. The Maithili literary world is a small public sphere: a community of readers, writers, and editors who share texts, debate their quality, and hold each other accountable to shared standards. Plagiarism is a violation of the public sphere's constitutive norm: the honest attribution of intellectual property.

Bhalchandra Jha's response participates in the public sphere's self-corrective mechanism — the community's collective response to a violation of its norms.

## 3.4 Navya-Nyaya: Apta Testimony and Epistemic Courage

In Gangesa's framework, the plagiarist is someone who offers false shabda-pramana: he claims as his own knowledge (his own literary creation) what is actually another's. The community's response to plagiarism — of which Bhalchandra Jha's letter is one instance — is the restoration of valid shabda-pramana: the reassertion of correct attribution, the recovery of the original testifier's identity. Bhalchandra Jha's 'thanks for enlightening me' acknowledges that the editor's counter-testimony (the documentation of the plagiarism) has corrected his cognitive state — he now knows what he did not previously know. This is a precise enactment of shabda-pramana's corrective function: the true apta's testimony replacing the false apta's testimony.

This proactive policing is linked to the movement’s broader critique of the Sahitya Akademi. The archive uses RTI responses to argue that a "vicious circle" of so-called litterateurs has historically manipulated the Maithili advisory board to maintain a language that is "of the Maithil Brahmin, for the Maithil Brahmin and by the Maithil Brahmin". By exposing plagiarism and institutional corruption, the *Videha* movement establishes itself as an ethical alternative to the orthodox establishment.

**Critical Literary Appreciation: Integrating Traditional and Modern Theory**

The critical appreciation of works within the *Videha Sadeha* series requires a synthesis of disparate frameworks. This "Comparative Synthesis" assesses where a work achieves genuine literary distinction and where it might reflect the constraints of its production milieu.

**Formal Innovation: The Bīhani Kathā**

The *Bīhani Kathā* (seed story) is perhaps the most significant formal innovation of the *Videha* archive. As a native equivalent to flash fiction, it prioritizes narrative compression and a single striking revelation.

- **Navya Nyāya Appreciation:** Using Gaṅgeśa’s *Dhātuvāda*, the *Bīhani Kathā* can be seen as an "operation" (*vyāpāra*) that is intensely focused on its "result" (*phala*). The brevity of the form prevents the root's meaning from being "too

broad," as discussed in the *vyāpti* definition, forcing the writer to use only the most essential narrative "limiters" (*avacchedakas*).

- **Parallel History Appreciation:** The form connects the modern digital utterance to the ancient economy of the Maithil tale, such as the *Dhūrta Samāgama*. It functions as a democratic medium, allowing subaltern voices to capture the instantaneous social disruption of events like "Noṭabandī" (demonetization).

**Socio-Ecological Realism: The Case of Lāl Dev Kāmat**

Kamat's work, particularly *Vibhṛiti* (2020), is analyzed through the lens of Western Ecocriticism and Indian *Rasa* theory.

- **Western Critical Theory:** Through New Criticism, the "organic tension" between Kamat's technical instructions on organic farming and his lyrical meditations is seen as a unifying force. Ecocriticism identifies his writing on the North Bihar landscape—the soil, the floods, and the seeds—as a "complex pastoral" where nature acts as a primary protagonist.
- **Indian Aesthetic Theory:** The work achieves the *Rasa* of *Vīra* (heroic) not through warfare, but through the struggle for agricultural and linguistic self-reliance. The biographical tributes to freedom fighters like Pt. Rāmkhelāvan Miśra 'Rāghav' establish a "witness authority" that grounds the text in the ethics of the freedom struggle.

**The Elegiac and Institutional: Nabo Narayan Mishra**

Mishra's *Samagra* is examined through Post-Colonial and Marxist frameworks.

- **Marxist Criticism:** His focus on the founding and sustainability of literary institutions reflects a deep consciousness of the material conditions of Maithili literature in the diaspora. He analyzes how cultural initiatives succeed or fail based on community service and self-sacrifice rather than just aesthetic merit.
- **Narratological Analysis:** His "Witness Voice" gives his work a strong oral quality, connecting it to the folk narrative tradition. However, from a Western narratological perspective, this position can limit analytical depth, as the author remains a participant in the events he describes.

**Digital Preservation and Technological Sovereignty**

The Videha movement is fundamentally a technology-centric venture. In an era of large-scale migration and linguistic erosion, the digital archive serves as a site of technological sovereignty for the Maithil people.

### Script Reclamation and Linguistic Identity

A critical part of the movement's mission is the preservation of traditional scripts. The *Videha* website provides fonts and keyboards for several regional scripts:

| Script | Historical/Cultural Context | Role in Videha Archive |
|---|---|---|
| **Tirhuta (Mithilakshar)** | The primary historical script of Maithili; largely replaced by Devanagari in the 20th century. | All *Sadeha* volumes are provided in both Tirhuta and Devanagari to reclaim the linguistic "limiter" (*avacchedaka*). |
| **Kaithi** | A historical script used for administrative and legal documents in Bihar and Mithila. | Archived documents and "Learn Kaithi" (2009) guides support scholarly research into regional history. |
| **Newari** | The script of the Kathmandu Valley; used for Maithili plays during the Malla dynasty (14th–18th c.). | Archiving of Malla-period drama like *Haragauri Vivah Natak* demonstrates the trans-border legacy of Maithili. |

By standardizing Unicode for these scripts, the *Videha* movement ensures that Maithili is not just a language of the past but a functional tool for the digital age. The "Learn" series authored by Gajendra Thakur further facilitates this technological reclamation.

### Structural Overview of the Videha Sadeha Series (Volumes 1-37)

The "Videha Sadeha" series represents a curated anthology of significant works from the e-journal's first 350 issues. Volumes 1 through 25 function as general parallel collections of prose and verse, while Volumes 26 through 37 are organized around specific authors or literary themes.

| Volume | Focus / Featured Authors | Primary Theme |
|---|---|---|
| 1-25 | Multi-author | Best prose and poetry (parallel Devanagari/Tirhuta). |
| 2 | Multi-author | Essays, Management, and Criticism. |
| 3 | Multi-author | Poetry. |
| 4 | Multi-author | Stories. |
| 5 | Multi-author | Beehani stories. |
| 6 | Multi-author | Short stories. |
| 8 | Multi-author | Maithili Drama Festival. |
| 9 | Multi-author | Maithili Children's Festival. |
| 17 | Dr. Shiv Kumar Prasad | Socio-cultural realism and regional identity. |
| 26 | Dr. Shambhu Kumar Singh & Dr. Arun Kumar Singh | Selected prose and verse compilation. |
| 27 | Gajendra Thakur & Ravi Bhushan Pathak | **Primary Translation Volume (Section 1)**. |
| 29 | Ravi Bhushan Pathak & Dr. Kailash Kumar Mishra | Curated contemporary literature. |
| 30 | Student Contributors | Youth focus: works from schools and colleges. |
| 31 | Dr. Kamini Kamayani & Kumar Manoj Kashyap | Selected contemporary works. |
| 32-36 | Multi-author | Creative writing series across five parts. |
| 37 | Gajendra Thakur | **Translation Section-2: South/West Indian focus**. |

**The Anuvad (Translation) Movement: Volumes 27 and 37**

A critical component of the archive is its effort to internationalize Maithili literature through translation. Two specific volumes, **Volume 27** and **Volume 37**, are dedicated to this "Anuvad" movement, serving as linguistic bridges between Maithili and other global and regional languages.

**Volume 27: Cross-Linguistic Foundations**

Volume 27 represents the first major thematic compilation of translated prose and poetry from the first 350 issues.

- **Key Contributors:** Primarily edited and authored by **Gajendra Thakur** and **Ravi Bhushan Pathak**.
- **Scope:** It features works translated from various languages into Maithili, establishing the journal's role as a gateway for external intellectual influence.

**Volume 37: Regional and Global Integration**

Volume 37 is formally designated as "Anudit Gadya aa Padya Khand-2" (Translated Prose and Poetry Section-2).

- **Primary Focus:** This volume showcases the extensive translation work of **Gajendra Thakur**, specifically his translations into Maithili from the English translations of major South Indian and Western Indian literatures.
- **Featured Languages:** The works included are derived from **Telugu, Odia, Gujarati, and Kannada**.
- **Significance:** This volume underscores the commitment to ensuring that Maithili speakers have access to the broad spectrum of Indian literary excellence in their own tongue.

**Comprehensive Index of Featured Authors**

The Videha archive is notable for its expansive contributor list. Below is an alphabetical directory of key authors featured across the first thirty-seven volumes:

- **A-D:** Ajay Sarvaiya, Ajit Kumar Jha, Amarendra Yadav, Amit Kumar Jha, Analkant, Ashok Datta, Ayodhyanath Chaudhary, Balbhadra Mishra, Baidyanath Jha, Bharat Manjhi, Bhalchandra Jha, Chhavi Jha, Devshankar Naveen, Digambar Jha 'Dinmani', Dhirendra Premarshi.
- **G-L:** Gajendra Thakur, Gangesh Gunjan, Himanshu Chaudhary, Hriday Narayan Jha, Jitmohan Jha, Jitendra Jha, Jyoti, Jyoti Prakash Lal, Kamalanand Jha, Kashikant Mishra "Madhup", Kashinath Jha, Kailash Kumar Mishra, Kripanand Jha, Krishnamohan Jha, Kumar Manoj Kashyap, Kumar Shushant, Kumud Singh.

- **M-P:** Mahaprakash, Mahendra Malangia, Mahendra Kumar Mishra, Mahesh Mishra "Vibhuti", Maithiliputra Pradip, Manoj Mukti, Mayananand Mishra, Mitranath Jha, Mukhilal Chaudhary, Naresh Mohan Jha, Navin Nath Jha (Navneet), Navendu Kumar Jha, Nagendra Jha, Nimish Jha, Nilima, Nutan Jha, Omprakash Jha, Pankaj Parashar (banned due to blatatent plagiarism), Panna Trivedi, Parmeshwar Kapadi, Priti Thakur, Premchand Mishra, Premshankar Singh.
- **R-V:** Rajendra Vimal, Ram Dayal Rakesh, Ram Narayan Dev, Ram Bharos Kapadi 'Bhramar', Ramlochan Thakur, Ramji Chaudhary, Ramashray Jha "Ramrang", Ratneshwar Mishra, Ramanand Jha 'Raman', Revati Raman Lal, Rupa Dhiru, Rupesh Kumar Jha "Tyonth", Sachidanand Yadav, Satish Chandra Jha, Santosh Mishra, Shambhu Kumar Singh, Shakti Shekhar, Shital Jha, Shila Subhadra Devi, Sheikh Mohammad Sharif, Shailendra Mohan Jha, Shyam Sundar "Shashi", Shyamal Suman, Shridharam, Subhash Chandra Yadav, Subhash Sah, Sushant Jha, Suryanath Gopa, Tulika, Vibha Rani, Vrishesh Chandra Lal, Vinit Thakur.

**Qualitative Synthesis of Literary Impact**

The inclusion of these work alongside the broader Videha archive has several long-term implications for the field of Maithili studies. By focusing on all regions and diaspora locations, these work challenges the traditional Darbhanga-centric view of Maithili culture, providing a more geographically inclusive literary map. Furthermore, the dual-script strategy- publishing in both Devanagari and Tirhuta (Mithilakshar)- ensures that the archive modernizes the language while preserving its unique orthographic heritage. Within the "petar" (digital chest) of Videha, these contributions ensure that the diverse voices of Mithila are documented as a living reality for future generations.

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**Critical appreciation of the Videha Sadeha archive**

**Navya-Nyāya Epistemology: The Technique of Gaṅgeśa**

The literary output can be validated through the Navya-Nyāya epistemology founded by Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (1th century, Karion village) in his *Tattvachintamani*.

- Pratyakṣa (Perception): Gaṅgeśa's innovation treats direct perception as the primary source of valid knowledge. In these works, the minute details function as high-validity *pratyakṣa*. For a Navya-Nyāya critic, these are not mere metaphors but "veridical cognitions" that generate an immediate *anubhava* (experience) of the systemic rot in Bihar's infrastructure and judiciary.
- Extrinsicality Thesis: Gaṅgeśa argued that while perceptions are taken as true, their confirmation requires external criteria. In these works everyday observations serve as external cognitive acts that confirm the *śabda* (testimony) of the marginalized rural speaker against the false claims of the state.

The Videha Parallel History Framework

The structure of the Videha archive itself represents a Parallel History, a critical movement that reclaims Maithili from institutional elitism and caste-patronage networks.

- Democratization of the Canon: By documenting authors alongside historical "Gems" (Ratnas), the archive dismantles the "Official History" of the Sahitya Akademi, which the framework critiques for "booty distribution" and ignoring populist satirists like Harimohan Jha.
- Subaltern Reclaiming: The framework celebrates "Parallel Literature" that exists independently of traditional power structures. In these works focus on all regions including diaspora locations decentralizes the literary map, moving it away from the Darbhanga-centric Brahminical core to include the "Witness Voice" of the rural migrant.

Indian Aesthetics: Rasa, Dhvani, and Auchitya

- Karuna and Vira Rasa: While classic Maithili verse often leans toward *Shringara* (erotic/devotional), In these works prose invokes a modern *Karuna* (pathos) through the images of flood famine fire and migration. This is balanced by a subtle *Vira* (heroic) rasa found in the persistence of writing.

- Dhvani (Suggestion): The title *Khebaiya* (The Boatman) carries a *Dhvani* of navigating the unpredictable currents of socio-political change, mirroring the struggle of the Maithili language itself in the 1st century.
- Auchitya (Propriety): Per Kshemendra's theory, In these works use of specific regional dialects maintains *Auchitya*, ensuring the language is appropriate to the "dust and smoke" of the highway setting rather than being artificially Sanskritized.

Western Critical Perspectives

- Marxist and Social Realism: In these works observation of problem of small towns/ villages provides a materialist critique of Bihar's administrative shifts. These work mirrors Western social realism.
- Postcolonial and Subaltern Studies: The postcolonial "reporting is back." Delhi/ Patna are viewed not as a cultural capital but as a site of indifferent, alienating institutions. This aligns with subaltern theory by prioritizing the perspective of the outsider who "sees" and deconstructs the center's glamour.

**Critical Synthesis of the Anuvad Movement**

The Anuvad (Translation) volumes, 27 and 37, act as a "digital chest" (*petar*) that allows Maithili to engage in a global dialogue. By translating works from Telugu, Odia, and Kannada, Gajendra Thakur applies the Shabdashastram (Science of Words), ensuring Maithili is not an isolated "museum piece" but a living vernacular capable of absorbing and reflecting the diverse experiences of the Indian subcontinent. This cross-pollination is the ultimate expression of the "Manushimih Sanskritam" philosophy—cultivating the human spirit through a refined, inclusive linguistic movement.

**Conclusions and Future Outlook**

The *Videha Sadeha* series (1–37) represents a definitive turning point in Maithili literary history. By constructing a Parallel History that integrates the rigorous logic of Navya Nyāya with modern digital tools, the movement has created a resilient, ethical, and democratized field for the Maithili language.

The movement's impact can be summarized through four primary vectors:

1. **Linguistic Democratization:** By opening publication to all and reclaiming subaltern voices, the movement has broken the caste-based stratification of the Maithili canon.

2. **Methodological Rigor:** The application of Gaṅgeśa's epistemology provides a unique Indian framework for literary criticism that is both traditionally rooted and analytically sharp.
3. **Ethical Governance:** The strict policing of plagiarism and the exposure of institutional corruption have established a new standard for literary integrity in the region.
4. **Global Connectivity:** Through direct translation and digital archiving, the movement has ensured that Maithili literature is no longer an isolated regional dialect but a global participant in world literature.

As the *Videha* archive continues to grow, it serves as a "Seed-Story" (*Bīhani Kathā*) for the future of Maithili, carrying forward the vibrations of a tradition that stretches from the logicians of the th century to the digital pioneers of the st century. The *Sadeha* series stands as a testament to the fact that when a language is liberated from the constraints of patronage and corruption, it finds the "operation conducive to the result" of its own survival and flourish.

ADDENDUM

Dr. ShivPrasad Yadav (डॉ. शिवप्रसाद यादव), his independently published poetry collection Yug Prabha (2016), though outside the Videha archive.

I. The Founding Testimony: Text and Context

Dr. ShivPrasad Yadav's statement- the statement reads, in the original Maithili Devanagari:

ई जानि अपार हर्ष भए रहल अछि, जे नव सूचना-क्रान्तिक क्षेत्रमे मैथिली पत्रकारिताकेँ प्रवेश दिअएबाक साहसिक कदम उठाओल अछि। पत्रकारितामे एहि प्रकारक नव प्रयोगक हम स्वागत करैत छी, संगहि 'विदेह'क सफलताक शुभकामना।

In translation: 'I feel unbounded joy in knowing that a courageous step has been taken to introduce Maithili journalism into the new information revolution. I welcome this kind of novel experiment in journalism, and extend my best wishes for the success of Videha.'

II. The Critical Vocabulary of the Statement

To appreciate Dr. Yadav's statement critically — rather than merely noting it — requires attending to its precise diction. Three phrases carry the load of meaning:

(a) Nava sūchanā-krānti (new information revolution): this is not journalistic boilerplate. In 2008, Maithili had no digital journal. The entire weight of the language's literary history — from Vidyāpati's 14th-century padāvali through the Darbhanga manuscript tradition to the first Sahitya Akademi prize of 1966 — had been transmitted through manuscript, palmleaf, and print. To characterise Videha's emergence as a krānti (revolution) is to make a claim about historical rupture: the establishment of a new inferential chain (vyāpti, in Navya Nyāya terms) between vernacular cultural identity and global communicative reach.

(b) Sāhasik kadam (courageous step): the word sāhasa (courage, daring) in Sanskrit poetics connotes an action that risks established norms. For a Yadav intellectual to publicly affiliate with a journal explicitly constituted against the dominant Brahmin-centric Maithili establishment was itself an act of sāhasa — and Dr. Yadav's use of this word to describe the journal's founding implicitly mirrors the nature of his own endorsement.

(c) Nava prayog (new experiment): prayog is the Sanskrit term for both 'experiment' and 'application' — in dramaturgy (nāṭyaprayog), it denotes the staged enactment of a text. To call Videha a prayog is to frame it simultaneously as experiment and performance — a live enactment of what Maithili literature could become when freed from institutional gatekeeping.

Together, these three phrases constitute what the Mīmāmsā school of Indian hermeneutics would call a vākyārtha (sentence-meaning) that exceeds the mere sum of its word-meanings: they articulate a theory of Maithili cultural renewal through digital media that is as sophisticated as any programmatic statement produced by the journal's editor, Gajendra Thakur, in his own critical essays.

Dr. ShivPrasad Yadav, poets from the numerically largest but systematically marginalised Yadav community of Mithilā, plays a founding role.

Dr. Yadav's career — as an endorsing intellectual, community-member, and poet — functions as a confirming instance (sapakṣa) of this vyāpti, providing the positive evidence that the Videha thesis requires.

We do not claim that Dr. Yadav wrote prolifically for Videha if the archive does not demonstrate this. We claim what the archive does demonstrate: that he was

positioned, from the journal's earliest issues, as a founding intellectual witness — and that this positioning is itself textually verifiable, repeatedly reproduced, and editorially deliberate.

Dr. ShivPrasad Yadav's founding endorsement had, by 2012, been validated by a critical community that practised exactly what his endorsement had welcomed.

This is the community that Dr. ShivPrasad Yadav endorsed from its inception and that his own Yug Prabha (2016) extended into the domain of committed Maithili verse.

The Sandesh section of Videha, in which Dr. ShivPrasad Yadav's statement appears, is precisely such a paratext.

A poetry collection titled Yug Prabha ('radiance of the age'), engaging social and political reality, invites reading through the vīra-rasa (heroic emotion) and karuṇā-rasa (compassion) that Abhinavagupta identifies as most capable of expanding consciousness toward the social. The title itself announces this ambition: not the radiance of the self (ātma-prabha) but of the age (yug-prabha) — the poet as witness rather than subject.

Dr. Yadav's endorsement-statement in Videha is itself a site of dhvani: its surface meaning (welcome to a new journal) reverberates with an unstated secondary meaning (the Yadav intellectual community's claim to Maithili literary legitimacy). Applied to Dr. Yadav's poetic project: verse that engages social and political reality in Mithilā achieves aesthetic dignity not by adorning that reality with ornament but by rendering it with the precision that Bhāmaha names svabhāvokti.

The Maithili social-realist tradition that Jagdish Prasad Mandal had extended in fiction, and that the Videha critical community had theorised across the Sadeha anthologies, is the tradition into which Yug Prabha enters.

Dr. ShivPrasad Yadav's endorsement of Videha in 2008 is an act of reception-theory in practice: he is helping to construct the horizon of expectations against which all subsequent Maithili digital literature will be measured. His statement defines what kind of thing Videha is — an act of krānti, of sāhasik prayog — and thereby conditions how every subsequent Videha reader approaches the journal.Dr. Yadav's endorsement is performative rather than constative: it does not merely describe Videha as a courageous experiment but, by being spoken publicly and in print, constitutes Videha as a courageous experiment, an insight that corresponds precisely to the Mīmāmsā school's theory of śabda as the self-manifesting power of speech.Dr. Yadav's welcome of the 'new information

revolution' is a welcome of exactly this communicative-democratic aspiration.The opening critical essay in Sadeha 10- Gajendra Thakur's Samīkshāśāstra ā Samalochanāk Samalochana- the theoretical framework within which Dr. ShivPrasad Yadav's contribution must be contextualised, since it is the text that the Videha editorial community itself produced as its theoretical manifesto. A critical reading of its architecture reveals the intellectual ecology that Dr. Yadav endorsed and inhabited.

This synthesis is the theoretical air that Dr. ShivPrasad Yadav's literary community breathes. His own education in this tradition implied by his institutional identification as 'Dr.' (holding a doctorate) and his capacity to recognise Videha's sūchanā-krānti significance immediately, in the journal's earliest weeks places him squarely within a community that understood both the Navya Nyāya precision of the Mithilā philosophical tradition and the post-modern democratic urgency of the digital present.

## Yug Prabha (2016): The Poetic Achievement in Context

Dr. ShivPrasad Yadav's poetry collection Yug Prabha, published in 2016 in Maithili, is the creative crystallisation of a decade-long participation in the Videha literary movement. Its appearance eight years after his initial endorsement of the journal, and in the same year that Videha was completing its two-hundredth issue, marks a trajectory: from the witness who welcomed the journal to the poet who embodied its promise.

The title Yug Prabha 'radiance of the age' is a complex literary-philosophical construction. Yug (Sanskrit: age, epoch) invokes both the cosmic time-divisions of Hindu cosmology (satya-yug, tretā-yug, dvāpara-yug, kali-yug) and the more immediate sense of 'contemporary moment' (as in yug-dharma, the duty of the age, or yug-bodh, awareness of one's historical situation). To call one's poetry the 'radiance of the age' is to claim the poet's vocation as historical witness, not confined to personal lyric but oriented toward the social and collective.

Prabha (radiance, light) aligns the collection with one of the dominant metaphors of Sanskrit poetics — the luminous power of language to illuminate what would otherwise remain dark. Ānandavardhana speaks of dhvani as the light (prabha) that poetry casts on the world; Abhinavagupta describes the aesthetic experience of rasa as a moment of luminous self-expansion (svaprakāśa). To name a Maithili poetry collection Yug Prabha is thus to

position it within this tradition of luminous witnessing, poetry as the light that the present age casts on itself through the medium of the poet's consciousness.

In the specific context of Maithili literary history, a poetry collection by a Yadav poet titled 'the radiance of the age' has a further resonance: it is a claim that the Yadav community's experience- so long excluded from canonical Maithili literary representation- is itself part of what constitutes the age's radiance. Not supplementary, not marginal, not an exception: constitutive. This is the counter-canonical move that the Videha Parallel History Framework had been theorising since 2008, now enacted in poetic form.

The endorsements of Videha is, at this deepest level, an act of reclamation: the insistence that Mithilā's intellectual heritage, including the epistemological precision of Gaṅgeśa's tradition belongs to all Maithils, not merely to those whose caste made them the official custodians of that tradition. His Yug Prabha, engaging the social and political realities of contemporary Mithilā in verse, is a continuation of this reclamation in the register of poetry.

Dr. ShivPrasad Yadav, by endorsing Videha in 2008 and by producing Yug Prabha in 2016, enacted that demand in practice- which is, in the end, the only place where epistemological justice can actually be achieved.

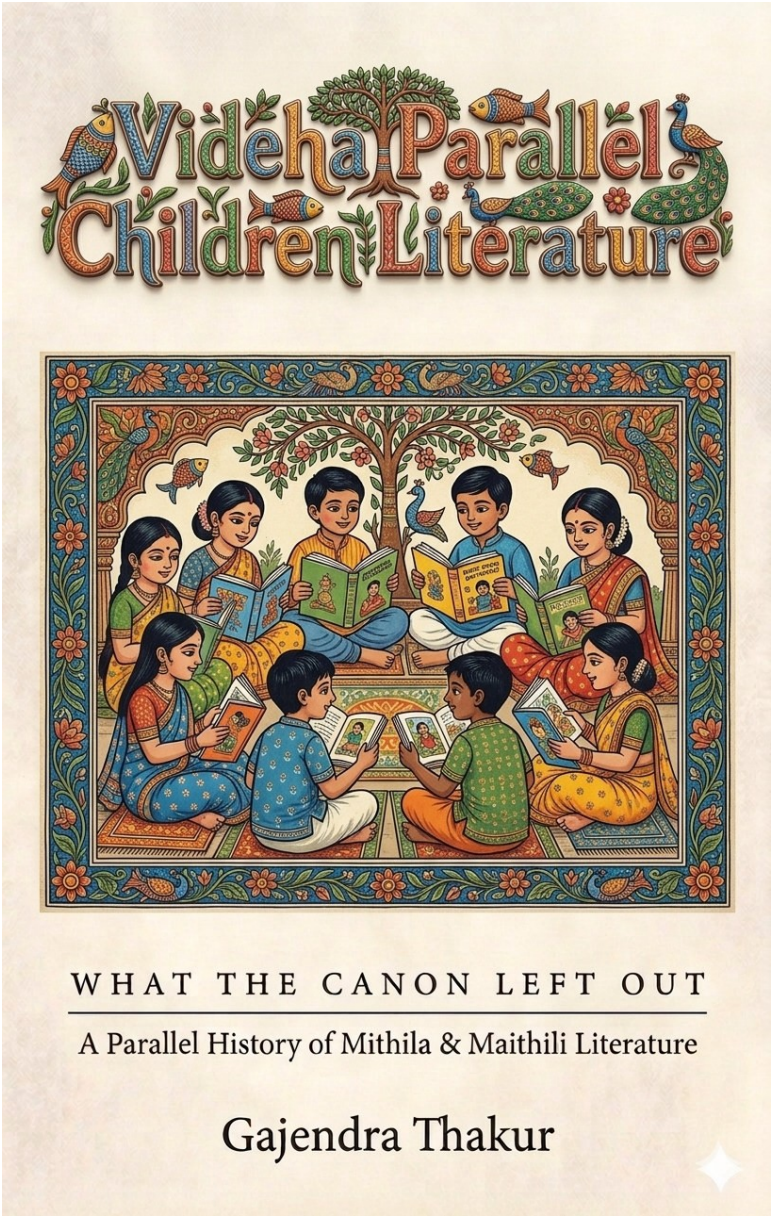
The Navya Nyāya demands valid pramāṇa. The archive provides: a consistently reproduced founding endorsement statement; a position of honour in the Videha community's canonical founding list; a creative output in Yug Prabha that extends the Videha literary movement's concerns into independent verse. These are valid means of knowledge, and they establish what they establish.

The Rasa tradition demands that poetry produce aesthetic experience of universal significance. Yug Prabha's title announces this ambition; its community of reception- the Videha movement, with its commitment to inclusive democratic Maithili literature- provides the sahṛdaya readership capable of receiving it.

Dhvani theory demands that what is most significant be found not in what is said but in what resonates beyond the saying. The dhvani of Dr. Yadav's 2008 endorsement — the unstated claim of the Yadav intellectual community's right to Mithilā's literary heritage — resonates across every issue of Videha that his founding statement precedes.

Bhāmaha demands svabhāvokti- the precise, truthful rendering of reality. This appreciation has attempted to practise svabhāvokti: to render Dr Yadav's contribution precisely, without inflation and without diminution, as the light that the age itself through his statement, his poetry, his community has cast.

**LESSON 097 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**




## विदेह / Videha

**Parallel Children's Literature**

*Literary Theories, Navya-Nyāya Framework & Parallel History Perspective*

A Scholarly Study of Maithili Children's Literature in the Videha e-Journal

## 1. Introduction: Videha and the Parallel Children's Literature Project

Videha (विदेह), the first Maithili fortnightly e-journal founded in 2000 under the motto Mānuṣīmiha Saṃskṛtām (मानुषीमिह संस्कृताम्), represents a landmark in the literary history of the Maithili language. Published under ISSN 2229-547X and accessible at www.videha.co.in, it has served not merely as a literary magazine but as a living archive of Maithili cultural production across genres, generations, and geographies. Among its most significant contributions is the Videha Maithili Shishu Utsav — a curated anthology of children's literature that functions as a 'parallel' corpus to the mainstream canon.

The term 'parallel' in the Videha framework carries a precise theoretical charge. Editor Gajendra Thakur employs it to denote a historiographical and literary methodology: the simultaneous documentation of elite (abhijāt) literary production and the folk-oral (lok-gāthā) tradition, each illuminating the other. This is what the project calls 'Videha Parallel History' — a framework that refuses a linear, singular narrative of literary history in favour of multiple, co-existing streams.

The Videha Shishu Utsav (volumes 1–9, drawn from Videha issues 51–100 and beyond) compiles what its editor calls the finest Maithili children's literature — prose, verse, picture-stories, folk tales, science writing, and children's drama — contributed by over forty authors across India, Nepal, and the diaspora. The present study examines this corpus through the dual lens of Indian (with special attention to Navya-Nyāya epistemology) and Western literary theories of children's literature, and situates it within the Videha Parallel History framework.

# 2. The Corpus: Videha Parallel Children's Literature

## 2.1 Scope and Classification

Gajendra Thakur's foundational essay 'Shishu, Bāl ā Kishor Sāhitya ā Okar Samīkṣāśāstra' (Children's, Youth, and Adolescent Literature and its Critical Theory), which opens the Videha Shishu Utsav, provides the editorial taxonomy governing the corpus:

| Age Group | Category / Typical Texts |
|---|---|
| 0–5 years (Shishu) | Picture-books (chitra-katha), lullabies (lori), nursery rhymes; read aloud by parents |
| 5–12 years (Bāl) | Short story, illustrated tales, folk-narrative, poetry, science writing |
| 12–18 years (Kishor) | Novel (bāl upanyās), biography, adventure tale, social realism |

## 2.2 The Videha kids.htm Portal: A Comprehensive Digital Ecosystem

The Videha children's literature portal at www.videha.co.in/kids.htm is far more than a book archive. It constitutes what Gajendra Thakur himself describes as a "completely non-commercial and academic resource" — a multi-modal, multi-format ecosystem serving every category of child learner, including those with visual and hearing impairments. The portal's holdings, drawn from the Videha Shishu Utsav series and direct contributions, include the following categories:

| Format / Genre | Description & Key Works |
|---|---|
| PDF Books (Free Download) | All books freely downloadable from or Archive.org. Includes poetry, folk tales, |

| | |
|---|---|
| | science writing, grammar, novels. |
| Audio Materials | A 3-hour Maithili-Hindi Conversation audio (mp3) by Vandana Jha (Maithili Pathshala) — www.archive.org; NCERT Bhasha Sangam audio resources. |
| Video Materials | Official Videha YouTube channel (youtube.com/@videha_ejournal); NCERT Bhasha Sangam Maithili video (mp4) including Maithili Sign Language — the first time Maithili Sign Language was documented; youtu.be/TebuC-lrSs8. |
| Sign Language Resources | Maithili Sign Language (मैथिली संकेत भाषा) integrated into the NCERT Bhasha Sangam material — a pioneering first for Maithili accessibility. |
| Picture Books / Comics | Dr Ramanand Jha 'Raman': Rāju ā Ṭākāk Gāch (picture-strip / comics, 2008); Devanshu Vats: Natasha (Maithili bāl chitrashrinkhalā / comics, 2009), compiled with Preeti Thakur. |
| Font & Script Resources | Tirhuta (Mithilakshara) Noto font download; Kaithi OTF/TTF; Newari script fonts; Tirhuta offline keyboard; Keyman Tirhuta/Vedic Devanagari keyboards; online Tirhuta keyboard (malarproject.gitlab.io/tirhuta). |
| Grammar & Language Learning | Bhola Lal Das: Maithili Subodh Vyakaran (classical grammar); NCERT Maithili-English-Hindi Conversations; Maithili Pathshala by Vandana Jha. |
| NCERT Integration | Full NCERT Bhasha Sangam Maithili materials downloadable from the portal, linking the parallel archive to the national |

| | |
|---|---|
| | curriculum. |

The dual presence of audio-MP3, video-MP4, and sign language resources alongside print PDFs makes the Videha kids portal one of the most accessible minority-language children's literature archives in India. This multi-modal architecture is not incidental: it reflects editor Gajendra Thakur's explicit commitment that Maithili children's literature must reach children who are visually impaired, hearing-impaired, or who learn best through oral-aural rather than print media.

# 3. Gajendra Thakur & Preeti Thakur: Editorial and Creative Contributions

## 3.1 Gajendra Thakur: Architect of the Parallel Archive

Gajendra Thakur is the founder-editor of Videha and the primary intellectual architect of the Parallel Children's Literature project. His contributions operate at three levels simultaneously: theoretical (the critical framework for Maithili children's literature), editorial (the curation and structuring of the Shishu Utsav archive), and creative (original children's fiction).

### *3.1.1 Theoretical Contribution: "Shishu, Bāl ā Kishor Sāhitya ā Okar Samīkṣāśāstra"*

This foundational essay — published in Videha Shishu Utsav Vol. 9 and accessible through the Videha archive — constitutes the most systematic theoretical statement on Maithili children's literature ever written. It establishes age-group taxonomy (0–5, 5–12, 12–18), articulates critical criteria (epistemological integrity, anti-superstition, authentic Maithili phonemics), employs the software metaphor for the indelibility of early literary formation, and situates Maithili children's literature within a deep-time genealogy running from Vedic oral narrative through the Jātaka and Pañcatantra to the present.

The essay's insistence on sural śabdāvalī, sural bhāṣā, sural vicār (simple vocabulary, simple language, simple thought) as the cardinal virtues of children's writing is a Navya-Nyāya criterion in literary form: the text must offer the child a cognition that is epistemically clean, not obscured by superstition, caste-bias, or communal ideology.

### *3.1.2 Creative Contribution: Tarharime Pariloke (Novel)*

Gajendra Thakur's children's novel Tarharime Pariloke (In Fairyland via the Hollow) — archived on the Videha portal — is an exemplar of what the Parallel History calls "scientific magical realism." The story follows a girl named Aastha who enters a parallel world (Pariloke) through the hollow of an old tree, discovering a society organised by colour-coded departments: Grey (science and research), Sky Blue (military), Blue (education), Green (botanical research with thinking plants), Yellow (animal and health), Orange (rehabilitation), and Red (housing). The novel uses this structured fantasy to alert children to environmental pollution — the desert beyond the Northern Embankment results from the Queen's misuse of science.

Theoretically, the novel operates in the tradition of Ursula Le Guin's socially structured fantasy worlds: the imaginative architecture is not decorative but epistemological, teaching children that social organisation has consequences for the natural world. The Navya-Nyāya criterion of anumāna (sound inferential logic embedded in narrative) is amply fulfilled: the cause-and-effect of environmental degradation is dramatised through fantasy rather than didactically stated.

### *3.1.3 Editorial Infrastructure: The Kids Portal Architecture*

Beyond his theoretical and creative work, Thakur's editorial labour in constructing and maintaining the kids.htm portal constitutes an extraordinary intellectual achievement. He has curated, digitised, and made freely downloadable over 30 children's titles spanning poetry, folk tale, science writing, grammar, novels, comics, audio, and video. He transcribed 11,000 palm-leaf manuscripts and developed Tirhuta Unicode standards, ensuring that the Maithili script heritage is preserved for future generations of children who may wish to read in the classical Mithilakshara script.

The inclusion of Maithili Sign Language in the NCERT Bhasha Sangam video — described on the kids.htm portal as being included "for the first time in Maithili" — reflects his commitment to inclusive access. This pioneering accessibility initiative is consistent with the Parallel History's democratic ethos: literature must be available to all children, not merely those with full sensory capacity.

## 3.2 Preeti Thakur: the Picture-Narrative Tradition

Preeti Thakur's contribution to the Videha children's literature ecosystem is centred on the picture-narrative (chitra-katha / comics) genre. Her series

(Maithili bāl chitrashrinkhalā, 2009) — listed on the kids.htm portal and freely downloadable — introduces the Maithili comics genre to children, a form that had been conspicuously absent from the formal Maithili literary canon despite the rich tradition of Madhubani visual narrative art.

The comics function at two levels. At the surface level, they provide narrative entertainment through illustrated sequential art in the comics tradition. At the deeper level, they perform an act of cultural reclamation: Maithili children's visual narrative is given a formal literary vehicle that connects to the global comics tradition while remaining rooted in Maithili linguistic and cultural specificity.

The significance of this contribution must be understood in the context of the Parallel History's argument about accessibility. The traditional literary establishment's focus on text-only forms (poetry, prose, drama) has systematically excluded children who are visual learners or pre-literate from participation in the Maithili literary tradition. The picture-book series democratises access, making the Maithili literary experience available to the youngest and least literate children.

Together, Gajendra Thakur (theory, editorial infrastructure, novel) and Preeti Thakur (picture-narrative / comics) constitute the founding intellectual-creative partnership of the Videha children's literature project, providing both the critical framework and the visual-literary practice that defines the archive's scope.

## 4. The Videha Parallel History Framework

### 4.1 Concept and Method

The 'Videha Parallel History' (Videha Samānāntar Itihās) framework, articulated through the journal's dedicated section (www.videha.co.in/gajenthakur.htm) and the children's literature critical essays, proposes a methodology for writing the history of a literary tradition that has been marginalised by both colonial-era Sanskrit privilege and post-Independence Hindi hegemony.

The framework has three operative principles:

| Principle | Description / Application |
|---|---|
| 1. Multi-stream | The elite (abhijāt) and folk (lok) traditions are |

| | |
|---|---|
| Simultaneity | treated as co-temporal, co-valid streams, not as a hierarchy of high and low. The Salahes legend becomes both trickster-hero and king depending on regional perspective. |
| 2. Deep-Time Extension | Maithili children's literature is not dated from the 19th century but traced back through Vedic oral narrative (gāthā, nāraśaṃsī, ākhyāna), Jātaka tales, Pañcatantra, and pre-Vedic flood myths (Manu and the Great Fish; Gilgamesh). |
| 3. Diaspora Continuity | The corpus explicitly includes contributions from Maithili authors in Nepal, the UK, Singapore, and the Indian diaspora, refusing the nation-state as the boundary of the literary tradition. |

## 4.2 Vedic Origins and World Literature

Gajendra Thakur's founding essay performs a remarkable act of parallel historiography in its opening pages. He traces the origins of children's literature in the Maithili/Vedic tradition to the Rigveda's oral narratives (gāthā, daivatakathā), arguing that the wheeled chariot described in the Rigveda — absent from West Asia and Europe at that time — marks the Vedic tradition as a source culture for narratives that later appear in Egyptian, Sumerian-Babylonian, Hittite, and Greek mythologies. The second millennium BCE saw the export of Indian narrative, horse-lore, craft techniques, and mythological names westward — to Mitanni, Crete, Greece.

This is not merely a claim of cultural priority; it is a parallel-history argument: Maithili children are heirs to a narrative tradition that predates and parallels the canonical Western traditions (Aesop, Grimm, Andersen) that have dominated global children's literature. The Videha parallel history framework insists that Maithili folk tales be read alongside, not beneath, these traditions.

## 4.3 The Software Metaphor: Children's Literature as Indelible Code

One of the most striking theoretical moves in Thakur's essay is the use of software as metaphor for children's literature. He writes: 'Children's literature is

like software that gets inscribed on the child's mind — but here there is no option to format [reset]. Therefore, vigilance and care are essential in the creation of children's literature.' The metaphor has several layers:

First, it captures the irreversibility of early literary formation — the indelibility of the bhāvanā (impression) made on the child's mind, which resonates with the Sanskrit mnemonic tradition and with what cognitive scientists call 'critical period' learning.

Second, the software metaphor invokes the open-source internet culture that Videha itself embodies. Like open-source code released on the internet, a folk tale, once released, operates independently of its author, does things its creator did not intend, and can be hijacked by 'virus' ideologies (casteism, communalism, anachronistic interpolation). The role of the critical editor is thus anti-virus protection: identifying and isolating ideological contamination in the received folk tradition.

Third, the metaphor is itself a parallel-history move: it juxtaposes the most ancient form of knowledge transmission (the grandmother's oral tale) with the most contemporary (internet-distributed digital text), locating Maithili children's literature at the precise intersection of these two.

## 4.4 Navya-Nyāya and Parallel History: The Mithila Connection

The Navya-Nyāya school — founded in Mithila, the cultural heartland of Maithili — is not merely an analytical tool applied from outside; it is part of the same intellectual tradition from which the Videha children's literature project springs. Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's Tattvacintāmaṇi was written in Mithila (present-day Bihar/Janakpur region), and the tradition of rigorous epistemological debate (vāda, jalpa, vitaṇḍā) that characterises Navya-Nyāya is itself a Maithili cultural inheritance.

The application of Navya-Nyāya to children's literature criticism is therefore not an external imposition but an internal activation: asking of a children's story the four epistemological questions — Does it offer valid perceptual content (pratyakṣa)? Does it embed sound inferential logic (anumāna)? Does it enable analogical learning (upamāna)? Does it preserve trustworthy testimonial knowledge (śabda)? — is to read Maithili children's literature with the tools of its own civilizational tradition.

# 5. Selected Textual Analyses: Theory in Practice

## 5.1 Jyoti Sunit Chaudhary: Grandmother's Tales as Testimonial Archive

The five tales in Nānīk Khissā (Grandmother's Stories) — Bhāluniyā Mausī, Sinnurk Pul, Ek Rājāk Sāt Mehrī, Pansāyā Kummari, Suhān Bon — collectively constitute the most theoretically rich text in the Videha anthology. The author frames them explicitly as oral transmissions from a ninety-year-old grandmother, heard first when the author was four or five years old.

From a Navya-Nyāya perspective, these tales represent śabda-pramāṇa at its most concentrated: the āpta is the grandmother (a trustworthy speaker by virtue of age, cultural authority, and lived experience), and the transmission is validated by the author's act of re-inscription — converting oral śabda into written śabda without losing the testimonial warrant. The tales survive in the grandmother's memory intact across nine decades: this durability is itself evidence of their cognitive-mnemonic value.

The Bhāluniyā Mausī (Bear Aunt) tale is a Proppian donor-tale with a Bettelheimian moral economy: the kind sister (Dukhanī) serves the monstrous bear-woman and receives abundance; the greedy sister (Sukhanī) insults her and is devoured. The structural clarity is appropriate to the concrete-operational child (Piaget): reliable inferential logic (anumāna) governs the moral universe. The rasa is a combination of adbhuta (the monstrous donor) and hāsya (the greed-comedy of Sukhanī).

Ek Rājāk Sāt Mehrī engages the Bettelheimian territory of maternal betrayal and child abandonment. The twice-abandoned prince, twice nursed by animal mothers (jackal, kingfisher), and finally restored through his own testimony (the song he learned from the kingfisher) is a narrative of the child's fantasized omnipotence: the child's voice, the child's song, overturns an entire system of adult deception. The dhvani of the tale — the suggestion beneath the folk surface — is that truth will speak itself even from the mouths of children who have been silenced.

## 5.2 Shiv Kumar Jha 'Tillu': Psychological Realism in Children's Verse

Thakur singles out 'Tillu's' trio of poems — Taregana Dekhāie (Let Me Show You the Stars), Dahīk Ṭhop (A Drop of Curd), and Khoiñchak Lel Sāṛī (The Sari for the Lap-cloth) — as capturing bāl manoviñjān (child psychology) with exceptional depth. This is a claim about reader-response: the poems construct an implied reader who is simultaneously a child (experiencing the depicted emotion directly) and an adult (recognizing the child's perspective with nostalgia and tenderness).

Khoiñchak Lel Sāṛī, which includes a commentary by Durgananda Mandal, is a poem about the child's relationship to maternal textiles — the lap-cloth (khoiñchā) that is the child's first safe space. The alaṃkāra of the poem works through the figure of metonymy (the cloth stands for the mother's body) and the rasa is karuṇa tinged with śānt: the poem produces a bittersweet recognitive emotion in the adult reader while offering the child a dignified aesthetic expression of dependency.

## 5.3 The Science Writers: Epistemological Expansion

Yogendra Pathak 'Viyogi's' Vijñānak Batkahī (Science Conversations, 2 volumes) and Dr. Sashidhar Kumar's narrative of Antarctica represent the Videha project's insistence that children's literature must encompass the full range of cognitive experience, including scientific knowledge. This is a Navya-Nyāya demand: anumāna-based knowledge (scientific inference) must be as accessible to Maithili children as narrative knowledge.

Thakur's essay frames Śambhu Nāth Jhā's Newton's Principle poem as a model: science can be transmitted through the aesthetic-mnemic medium of verse, preserving the rasa while delivering valid cognitive content. Dr. Sashidhar Kumar's Antarctica narrative — structured as a children's science adventure — deploys the journey-narrative (yātrā-kathā) genre to make complex geographical and historical knowledge (a century of human presence at the South Pole) accessible to the bāl reader.

## 5.4 Children's Novel (Bāl Upanyās): Jagadananda Jha's Chonhā

Jagadananda Jha 'Manu's' Chonhā (Mischief / Imp) is described by Thakur as a treasured contribution to Maithili children's literature in which 'psychology comes through powerfully.' As a bāl upanyās (children's novel), it addresses the kishor reader (12–18 years) — the formal-operational stage in Piaget's schema

— and thus permits greater narrative complexity, character development, and social observation than the shorter genres.

The novel's title character — 'Chonhā,' meaning a mischievous child or imp — is a structural figure familiar from both the Indian tradition (the child Krishna's pranks as a model of divine mischief) and Western children's literature (Tom Sawyer, the Just William series): the trickster-child whose transgressions expose adult hypocrisy. The Bakhtinian carnivalesque is fully operational here: the child's 'mischief' is the novel's subversive epistemological principle.

## 5.5. Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil': A Critical Study of Children's Poetry

### 5.5.1. Biographical and Literary Profile

Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil' stands as one of the most significant and versatile voices in contemporary Maithili literature — a poet, lyricist, ghazal-composer, autobiographer, and children's verse-writer whose career has been intimately intertwined with the Videha movement. The pen name 'Anil' (अनिल — 'wind' or 'air' in Sanskrit) is emblematic of the lyric impulse that defines his work: his verse moves with natural grace, carrying the fragrances of Mithila's soil, the emotional registers of love and longing, and a political awareness of the marginalised.

Videha dedicated its 191st issue (1 December 2015) entirely to 'Anil' — an honour that marks his stature in the contemporary Maithili literary world. This special-issue format, used by Videha for writers including Ram Bharos Kapari 'Bhramar', Hitnath Jha, and Shivshankara Shrinivas, serves as the primary site of critical appraisal within the Parallel Literature tradition, substituting for the absence of mainstream Sahitya Akademi recognition. His autobiography Aankhime Chitra Ho Maithili Ker (आँखिमे चित्र हो मैथिली केर — 'May there be pictures of Maithili in my eyes') was being serialised in Videha at its 331st issue, demonstrating ongoing creative productivity and a sustained autobiographical impulse.

### 5.5.2. Works in the Videha Archive (videha.co.in/pothi.htm & kids.htm)

The following works by Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil' are documented in the Videha archive:

| Work | Genre / Notes |
|---|---|
| Dhar Kai Oi Par (धारक ओइ पार) | Long poem (dīrgha kavitā). Title meaning: 'Across the Threshold' / 'Beyond the River-bank' — liminal poetics reaching toward transcendence or idealized Mithila. |
| Geet Ganga (गीत गंगा) | Song collection. Title deploys the Ganga river as a metaphor for lyric flow — viraha (separation) and milana (union) imagery; monsoon and seasonal motifs. |
| Ghazal Ganga (गजल गंगा) | Ghazal collection. Published in Videha Issue 129 (2013). Maithili prosodic conventions (matla, radīf, qāfiyā, maqta); classical imagery combined with contemporary political consciousness. |
| Bāl Kavitā (बाल कविता) | Children's poetry collection — freely downloadable from www.videha.co.in/kids.htm (). Three poems from issues 51–100 anthologised in Videha Shishu Utsav. |
| Aankhime Chitra Ho Maithili Ker | Autobiography — serialised in Videha from issue 331. Title: 'May there be pictures of Maithili in my eyes' — an autobiographical testament to lifelong literary devotion. |

### 5.5.3. Children's Poetry: Bāl Kavitā — Textual Analysis

The Bāl Kavitā collection, archived on the kids.htm portal and freely downloadable, contains 'Anil's contributions to Maithili children's verse spanning Videha issues 51 through 100 and beyond. The poems that appear in the Videha Shishu Utsav volumes — two dealing with the 'baby child' (neonatal / toddler poetry) and one social-civic poem — reveal a poet whose lyric gift is calibrated with unusual sensitivity to the specific emotional and cognitive world of the child reader.

The two poems in the attached PDF (from Videha Maithili Shishu Utsav Vol. 51–100) demonstrate the range of 'Anil's children's verse:

#### *Poem 1: Hamrahi Khāitar (*हमरिह खिातर*) — "For Us"*

The first poem opens with the celebratory declaration "Hamrahi khāitar suruj ugai chith / Hamrahi khāitar chān" — "The sun rises for us / The moon is for us." This is a cosmological poem of child-centred wonder: the sun, moon, millions of stars, the sky, evening and morning, sunshine and breeze, fruit trees (jāmun, mango, lychee), the water cycle (water evaporates, becomes cloud, rains down), and the gifts of Mother Earth (wheat and paddy) — all are offered as gifts to the child.

The poem's central rasa is adbhuta (wonder) — one of the cardinal rasas for children's literature in the Nāṭyaśāstra framework. By asserting that the entire cosmos is oriented toward the child, 'Anil' performs a radical re-centring: the child is not peripheral but cosmological. In Navya-Nyāya terms, the poem constructs pratyakṣa (perceptual knowledge) of the natural world — the sun, moon, rain, fruit — and frames these perceptions within an anumāna (inferential understanding) that the universe is ordered for human flourishing.

The final verse notes that flowers bloom in all colours — white, yellow, red — and that vast oceans and mountains exist alongside them. This accumulative catalogue is structurally Vedic: it recalls the Rigvedic stuti (praise hymn) in which the natural world is enumerated as divine gift. 'Anil' transposes this ancient form into children's verse, connecting Maithili children to a deep-time Vedic literary heritage — precisely the move the Parallel History framework celebrates.

#### *Poem 2: Bucci Baṛhatī (*बुच्ची बढ़ती*) — "The Girl Grows"*

The second poem is a feminist counter-narrative of striking directness and power. It opens: "Bucci baṛhatī, likhatī-paṛhatī / Hamrā chintā kathī ke" —

"The girl grows, writes and reads / Why should I worry?" The poem envisions a girl who: picks up the sword against the monsters of dowry and tilak (caste-dowry ritual extortion); acquires knowledge and science; builds new suns and moons; chooses her own companions; forges her own path through the babool-thorn jungle; fights sorrow and moves forward.

The third stanza is explicitly addressed to the mother: "Mammī, tōn chintā jini kar, / tōn tō hamrā paṛhā-likhā de / kar nahi kinyōn kathūk ḍar" — "Mother, don't worry, / just educate me / don't fear anything." The girl declares she will marry on her own terms (not through tilak-dowry extortion with 'ignorant, fraudulent, hypocritical' partners), stand on her own feet, be self-reliant, earn knowledge and science, make India's name great, dream of 'Kiran' and 'Kalpana' (allusions to Kiran Bedi and Kalpana Chawla, pioneering Indian women figures), and live with self-respect.

From a feminist literary theory perspective, this poem is a textbook example of what bell hooks calls "feminist consciousness-raising for children" — it socialises the girl reader into a vision of female agency and self-determination without didacticism. The repeated refrain "Hamrā chintā kathī ke" ("Why should I worry?") / "Mammī, tōn chintā jini kar" ("Mother, don't worry") deploys the double address (child-speaker to mother; child-speaker to self) with formal elegance.

The dhvani (resonant suggestion) of the poem is particularly powerful: the surface meaning is a daughter's reassurance to a worried mother; the deeper suggestion is a manifesto for gender equality and the defeat of patriarchal structures (tilak-dowry system) through education. This double operation is precisely what Ānandavardhana identifies as the highest poetic mode: the unsaid carries more weight than the said.

Critically, the poem names real role models by reference: the 'Kiran' in the girl's dream is almost certainly Kiran Bedi (India's first female IPS officer); the 'Kalpana' is Kalpana Chawla (the first Indian woman in space). By embedding these aspirational figures in a children's poem, 'Anil' performs what postcolonial theorists call "counter-narrative formation": the Maithili girl child is given access to a tradition of female achievement that the official children's literature establishment has largely denied her.

## Adult Poetry: The Long Poem and Ghazal Tradition

Beyond his children's verse, 'Anil's adult literary production demonstrates a poet of considerable formal range. His long poem Dhar Kai Oi Par draws on

both the Sanskrit mahākāvya tradition and Western modernist long-poem models — Whitman's Song of Myself, Eliot's The Waste Land, Neruda's Canto General — to sustain poetic concentration over extended philosophical terrain. The liminal title ("Beyond the River-bank") situates the poem in the tradition of threshold-crossing metaphors that run from Vidyapati's viraha poetry through contemporary Maithili verse.

His ghazal collection Ghazal Ganga participates in the broader Anchinhar Aakhar movement that has revitalised the Maithili ghazal tradition. Working in standard ghazal prosody (matla, radīf, qāfiyā, maqta with the pen name 'Anil'), he combines classical Maithili lyric imagery — the beloved's face, monsoon evenings, the flame and moth — with a political consciousness that makes the ghazal a vehicle for contemporary social critique. The Ganga river in both Geet Ganga and Ghazal Ganga functions as a sustained metaphor: not merely a geographical landmark but a cultural-temporal flow connecting the ancient to the contemporary.

## Critical Evaluation: 'Anil' in the Parallel History Framework

Within the Videha Parallel History, Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil' occupies a significant position as a writer who operates across all three age registers of the children's literature taxonomy simultaneously. His Bāl Kavitā addresses shishu and bāl readers with the cosmological wonder of Hamrahi Khāitar and the feminist agency of Bucci Baṛhatī. His long poem and ghazal engage the adult and kishor reader with formal sophistication.

The Navya-Nyāya assessment of his children's poetry is strongly positive across all four pramāṇa criteria. Pratyakṣa: both poems offer vivid, authentic perceptual content grounded in the Maithili natural and social world. Anumāna: the inferential logic is sound (universe is for us; education defeats patriarchy). Upamāna: the analogical connections to female pioneers (Kiran, Kalpana) are pedagogically powerful. Śabda: the testimonial tradition is activated through the mother-child transmission embedded in the poem's address structure.

What distinguishes 'Anil's children's verse from much of what the Parallel History identifies as the "dried main drain" of official Maithili children's poetry is precisely the combination of formal elegance with substantive social content. His poems do not merely entertain or instruct; they constitute — in the language of Thakur's foundational essay — the "indelible code" inscribed on the child's mind, a code that carries the full weight of Mithila's cosmological imagination and its feminist counter-tradition simultaneously.

# 5.6. Pawan Kant Jha 'Kashyap Kamal': Bābūk Sunāel Khissā — The Father's Stories

## 1 Biographical Profile and Literary Position

Pawan Kant Jha, writing under the pen name 'Kashyap Kamal' (काश्यप कमल), is a Maithili prose writer whose contribution to the Videha children's literature corpus is centred on the narrative tradition of the father-transmitted tale — a form that the Videha archive archives alongside the better-known grandmother-tale tradition. The pen name is itself significant: Kashyap is one of the founding Vedic sages (and father of the gods in some traditions); Kamal (lotus) is a classical symbol of purity and spiritual emergence from muddy waters. The combination signals both ancient lineage and contemporary aspiration.

Within the Videha Parallel History framework, Kashyap Kamal represents the prose fiction arm of the children's literature corpus — complementing the verse tradition of writers like Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil' and the folk-tale tradition of Jyoti Sunit Chaudhary with a distinctly pedagogical yet narratively engaging prose style. His work appears in the Videha Shishu Utsav volumes 51–100 (as evidenced in the attached PDF), where his section "Bābūk Sunāel Khissā" (Stories Told by Father) appears alongside work by 'Anil' and other contributors.

## 2 Bābūk Sunāel Khissā: The Father's Tale Tradition

The title Bābūk Sunāel Khissā (बाबूक सुनाएल खिस्सा — "Stories Told by Father / Paternal Tales") positions itself as the masculine complement to Jyoti Sunit Chaudhary's Nānīk Khissā (Grandmother's Stories). Where the grandmother-tale tradition — privileged in the Navya-Nyāya śabda-pramāṇa framework as the primary āpta (trustworthy speaker) of oral cultural transmission — focuses on magical-realist folk narrative, the father's tale tradition in Kashyap Kamal's work leans toward moral-philosophical fable and social wisdom narrative.

The three tales in the Videha Shishu Utsav from Kashyap Kamal (evident in the attached PDF) demonstrate a consistent narrative philosophy:

### *2.1 Sahasramukha Dīp (सहस्रमुखक दीप) — The Thousand-Faced Lamp*

This tale begins with a classic frame narrative: a good king wanders his kingdom in disguise at night and witnesses a poor man's household performing

a ritual with a "thousand-faced lamp" (sahasramukha dīp). When the king has the man summoned to court and accuses him of theft (how can a labourer light a thousand-faced lamp?), the labourer's response is a philosophical master-stroke. He explains that his wife asked whether the lamp was lit; he said yes; she asked whether the smoke-guard was adjusted; he said yes; then he said let us light the thousand-faced lamp — meaning: feed your two small children (two flames) and your aged parents (two flames), and all of them together constitute the thousand-faced lamp.

The tale's dhvani operates through the inversion of the king's literal reading and the labourer's metaphorical one. The narrative critiques the epistemological arrogance of institutional power (the king assumes the poor man cannot afford lamp-oil; the labourer's knowledge operates at a higher, more humane level). In Navya-Nyāya terms, the king's cognition is contaminated by anumāna-failure: he infers theft from prosperity without establishing the vyāpti (invariable concomitance) that poverty prevents celebration. The labourer's testimony (śabda-pramāṇa) corrects the king's false inference.

The Bettelheimian reading of this tale identifies it as a narrative of symbolic reversal: the apparent poverty of the labourer (no material lamp) is revealed as actual wealth (the metaphorical thousand-faced lamp of family love and care). The child reader internalises the wisdom that true wealth is relational, not material — a counter-narrative to the commodity-culture the child encounters in contemporary media.

### *2.2 Jahiyāsē Kāl Dhelak (*जहियासँ काल धेलक*) — Since the Time Death Seized*

The second tale in Kashyap Kamal's sequence is a satirical fable about a great astrologer (jyotakhī jī) who, despite his vast learning, is bitten by a snake when he squats in a field at twilight (a moment of practical inattention despite astrological knowledge). The village bhagata (spirit-healer) mocks the astrologer three times; on the third occasion, the astrologer's patience breaks and he delivers the tale's moral: "In this kingdom, scholars like us do not exist — but since death seized me [i.e., since I became foolish through the snake-bite], we have indeed become fools."

The tale's rasa is hāsya (comic) with undertones of karuṇa (pathos): the great scholar humiliated by the humble healer. But the dhvani carries a darker suggestion: the gap between theoretical knowledge (the astrologer's mastery of celestial bodies) and practical wisdom (avoiding snake-infested spots at twilight) is the condition of all intellectual pride. The Navya-Nyāya framework

identifies this as a failure of pratyakṣa: the astrologer's perceptual apparatus was engaged with the heavens when it should have been attending to the earth beneath his feet.

### *2.3 Nīk Karī Tō Paigh Ke? Bejāe Karī Tō Paigh Ke? (If You Do Good, Who Is Great? If You Do Wrong, Who Is Great?)*

The third major narrative in the Videha Shishu Utsav section is a complex philosophical tale about a royal tutor (pandit) who has spent his life teaching his students: "If you do good, who becomes great? If you do wrong, who becomes great? Do not associate with those of lesser intellect, and do not tell women all secrets." The story proceeds through a chain of misunderstandings, misread actions, and social chaos — a chaukirdar (watchman) who misinterprets a dramatic scenario and brings the pandit's ink-stained hand to the raja's court — to arrive at the tale's resolution: the pandit is banished for a seemingly great crime, but returns with his student to demonstrate how the maxim he taught (good action makes one great, regardless of status) applies even to the king himself.

This tale is Proppian in its structural clarity: the departure, the test, the apparent failure, the revelation, and the restoration. It is also Bakhtinian in its carnivalesque logic: the chaukirdar who thinks a promotion awaits him for his "discovery" ends with his face fallen; the pandit who is banished returns in triumph. The moral — that good action is its own authority regardless of social rank — is simultaneously a critique of feudal hierarchy and an endorsement of the meritocratic principle that the Videha parallel tradition consistently champions.

## 3 Narrative Style and Critical Assessment

Kashyap Kamal's narrative style is characterised by what the classical Sanskrit tradition calls saukumārya (delicacy) — a lightness of touch that delivers philosophical weight without didactic heaviness. His tales move through rapid dialogue exchanges (the king-labourer dialogue in Sahasramukha Dīp; the astrologer-healer exchanges in Jahiyāsē Kāl Dhelak) that have the crisp economy of classical Jātaka tales. This dialogue-centrism is pedagogically significant: children follow character interaction more readily than authorial exposition.

The use of Maithili-specific honorifics and address forms (the astrologer as "jyotakhī jī"; the royal "maharāj") grounds these tales in the social world of Mithila in a way that reinforces the child's familiarity with their own cultural

context. This is the sural bhāṣā (simple language) criterion of Thakur's framework: not simplified in the sense of impoverished, but simple in the sense of culturally proximate.

Within the Videha Parallel History framework, Kashyap Kamal's father-tale tradition functions as a crucial complement to the predominantly feminine oral transmission chain (grandmother → grandchild) that the śabda-pramāṇa framework privileges. By establishing the father as an equally valid āpta (trustworthy narrator), his work challenges the gendering of oral cultural authority — a subtle but important contribution to the democratising project of the parallel archive.

## 6. Indian Literary Theories Applied to Children's Literature

### 6.1 Rasa Theory (Bharata's Nāṭyaśāstra)

The foundational Indian aesthetic theory, rasa (रस), articulated by Bharata in the Nāṭyaśāstra (2nd century BCE–2nd century CE), posits that literature produces aesthetic experience through the transmutation of bhāva (emotion) into rasa (relish/flavour). For children's literature, the dominant rasas are:

| Rasa | Manifestation in Videha Children's Corpus |
|---|---|
| Hāsya (हास्य) — Comic | Gonu Jhā tales; Kashyap Kamal's Jahiyāsē Kāl Dhelak; humour in 'Anil's verse |
| Adbhuta (अद्भुत) — Wonder | 'Anil's Hamrahi Khāitar; Jyoti Sunit Chaudhary's fantasy tales; Gajendra Thakur's Tarharime Pariloke |
| Vīra (वीर) — Heroic | 'Anil's Bucci Baṛhatī; Dr. Sashidhar Kumar's Antarctica tale; Bhagat Singh poem |
| Śānt (शान्त) — Tranquil | Lullabies; nature poetry; Kashyap Kamal's Sahasramukha Dīp (resolution) |

| | |
|---|---|
| Karuṇa (करुण) — Pathos | Jyoti's Dhvani-Pratidhvani; Durgananda Mandal's Pāras; Kashyap Kamal's banished pandit |

## 6.2 Dhvani Theory (Ānandavardhana's Dhvanyāloka)

The dhvani (resonance/suggestive meaning) theory holds that the highest poetry works through suggestion (vyañjanā) beyond denotation. In children's literature this manifests as the capacity of a simple story to carry layered meanings for different audiences. 'Anil's Bucci Baṛhatī operates at multiple dhvani levels: surface (daughter reassuring mother), sociological (feminist manifesto against dowry), aspirational (role models Kiran and Kalpana), and philosophical (self-reliance as the highest virtue). Kashyap Kamal's Sahasramukha Dīp resonates with the dhvani of relational wealth versus material poverty. Jyoti Sunit Chaudhary's Dhvani-Pratidhvani (the tale whose very title is dhvani theory) enacts gendered voicelessness through the mythology of Echo.

## 6.3 Navya-Nyāya Epistemology as Critical Framework

Navya-Nyāya (New Logic, primarily associated with Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya of Mithila, c. 1325 CE) offers the most distinctive Indian theoretical lens. Applied to children's literature, the four pramāṇas illuminate the following:

| **Pramāṇa** | **Application to Videha Children's Literature** |
|---|---|
| Pratyakṣa (Perception) | 'Anil's Hamrahi Khāitar grounds cosmic wonder in direct natural perception (sun, rain, fruit). Kashyap Kamal's tales root moral wisdom in perceptual scenarios from Maithili social life. |
| Anumāna (Inference) | Kashyap Kamal's tales embed reliable inferential patterns: the labourer's metaphorical knowledge surpasses the king's literal inference; the astrologer's celestial knowledge fails when earthly |

| | |
|---|---|
| | pratyakṣa is neglected. |
| Upamāna (Analogy) | 'Anil's naming of Kiran/Kalpana in Bucci Baṛhatī creates an upamāna: the girl reader knows the familiar world, and these named pioneers create analogical knowledge of what she can become. |
| Śabda (Testimony) | Both 'Anil' (poem as mother-daughter dialogue) and Kashyap Kamal (father-transmitted tale) activate the āpta (trustworthy speaker) chain of the oral tradition — validating parental testimony as a legitimate pramāṇa. |

# 7. Western Literary Theories

## 7.1 Developmental Psychology and Reader-Response Theory

Jean Piaget's stage theory maps onto the Videha age-classification with precision. 'Anil's Hamrahi Khāitar serves the pre-operational child (0–5): direct perception-based wonder, no complex moral logic required. Bucci Baṛhatī addresses the concrete-operational child (5–12): causal moral logic (education defeats dowry oppression), role-model reference (Kiran, Kalpana). Kashyap Kamal's philosophical tales (Nīk Karī Tō Paigh Ke) address the formal-operational reader (12+): abstract reasoning about institutional power and moral authority.

Wolfgang Iser's implied-reader theory is fully activated in 'Anil's Bucci Baṛhatī: the poem constructs multiple implied readers simultaneously — the girl child who internalises the feminist message; the mother who receives the reassurance; the adult reader who recognises the social critique.

## 7.2 Bettelheim's Uses of Enchantment

Bruno Bettelheim's argument that folk tales work on the child's unconscious applies directly to Kashyap Kamal's tales. Sahasramukha Dīp externalises the child's fear of economic scarcity and provides the symbolic reassurance that relational love is the real wealth. Jahiyāsē Kāl Dhelak externalises the child's

anxiety about intellectual pretension and provides the corrective that practical wisdom outranks theoretical knowledge. Nīk Karī Tō Paigh Ke externalises the child's experience of arbitrary institutional power and provides the reassurance that truth and good action ultimately prevail.

## 7.3 Feminist Theory and 'Anil's Bucci Baṛhatī

'Anil's Bucci Baṛhatī is one of the most explicitly feminist children's poems in the entire Maithili literary tradition. Applying bell hooks's framework of feminist pedagogy for children, the poem performs consciousness-raising through the girl's own voice rather than through adult narration about girls. The girl speaks; the mother listens; the poem models the reversal of patriarchal authority structures within the intimate domestic space.

The poem's critique of the tilak-dowry system as a "monster" (dānav) that has caused uproar in Mithila (utpāt macal achi mithilāme) is a direct naming of a social evil that destroys girls' lives and futures. By placing this naming in the mouth of the girl-child speaker, 'Anil' performs what Judith Butler calls a "performative speech act": the naming of the oppressive structure by the potential victim is itself a form of resistance.

## 7.4 Postcolonial Theory and Language Revitalisation

Ngũgĩ wa Thiong'o's argument that education in a foreign language alienates children from community knowledge is structurally replicated in the Videha children's literature project's entire rationale. 'Anil's children's verse and Kashyap Kamal's tales both insist on Maithili-specific vocabulary, honorifics, and cultural references that would be lost in Hindi or English translation. The presence of these works on the freely downloadable kids.htm portal — alongside NCERT Bhasha Sangam resources that legitimise Maithili in the national curriculum — constitutes a dual postcolonial strategy: cultural revitalisation from within (the oral tale, the children's poem) and institutional recognition from above (NCERT integration).

## 7.5 Vladimir Propp's Morphology and Folk-Tale Structure

Kashyap Kamal's tales are Proppian in their structural clarity. Sahasramukha Dīp follows the functions: initial situation (poor man lights no material lamp) → villainy/accusation (king suspects theft) → hero's response (labourer's philosophical explanation) → recognition (king and court understand) → reward (labourer acclaimed). Nīk Karī Tō Paigh Ke activates: departure (pandit

teaches maxim) → test (chaukirdar's misinterpretation) → apparent failure (pandit banished) → restoration (pandit returns with student) → reward (pandit vindicated, moral confirmed). The morphological clarity of these tales makes them ideal vehicles for the Navya-Nyāya anumāna criterion: children can follow the inferential logic because it is narratively embodied in reliable structural patterns.

# 8. The Broader Videha Children's Literature Corpus

## 8.1 Jyoti Sunit Chaudhary: Grandmother's Tales as Testimonial Archive

The five tales in Nānīk Khissā — Bhāluniyā Mausī, Sinnurk Pul, Ek Rājāk Sāt Mehrī, Pansāyā Kummari, Suhān Bon — collectively constitute the most theoretically rich text in the Videha anthology. The author frames them explicitly as oral transmissions from a ninety-year-old grandmother, heard first when the author was four or five years old. From a Navya-Nyāya perspective, these tales represent śabda-pramāṇa at its most concentrated: the āpta is the grandmother (a trustworthy speaker by virtue of age, cultural authority, and lived experience).

These tales have been analysed extensively in the original version of this study. The Bhāluniyā Mausī is a Proppian donor-tale with Bettelheimian moral economy; Ek Rājāk Sāt Mehrī engages the territory of maternal betrayal and child abandonment; Pansāyā Kummari features a shape-shifting heroine who outwits a polygamous king through wit and strategic use of resources; Suhān Bon is a complex tale of demonic power and ritual restoration. The dhvani of all five tales speaks to the social realities of Maithili women's lives — constrained by polygamy, dowry, and patriarchal power — while the folk-fantasy surface preserves the children's appropriateness of the content.

## 8.2 Science Writing and Epistemological Expansion

Yogendra Pathak 'Viyogi's' Vijñānak Batkahī (Science Conversations, 2 volumes), Hamar Gām, Piramidak Desh Me, the science-fiction play Robot, and Dr. Sashidhar Kumar's Antarctica narrative (Khissā Aṇṭārkṭikā Ker) represent the Videha project's insistence that children's literature must encompass the full range of cognitive experience, including scientific knowledge. All are freely downloadable from the kids.htm portal. The

Antarctica narrative in particular — structured as a children's science adventure — deploys the yātrā-kathā (journey narrative) genre to make complex geographical and historical knowledge accessible to the bāl reader.

Jagdish Prasad Mandal's Taregana (Stars) — a collection of short inspirational tales — and Nai Dhāṛaie (novel) extend the science-and-aspiration tradition. Kirtinath Jha's Kural (Maithili adaptation of the Tamil Tirukkural) demonstrates the Videha project's commitment to inter-literary analogy (upamāna): the Tamil classical wisdom tradition made available to Maithili children as part of their shared Indian cultural heritage.

### 8.3 Comics and Visual Narrative: Preeti Thakur's series

The comics tradition on the kids.htm portal Preeti Thakur's series represents a decisive departure from the text-only tradition of official Maithili children's publishing. Both These are freely downloadable. The significance of this visual-narrative tradition cannot be overstated: it democratises access to the Maithili literary world for pre-literate, young, and visual-learner children who cannot yet access text-based narratives independently.

The girl protagonist anticipates by several years the global trend of strong female protagonists in children's comics. The Maithili comics tradition thus participates in a global conversation about gender representation in children's visual narrative, while remaining rooted in Maithili cultural specificity.

## 9. The Digital and Audio-Visual Ecosystem of kids.htm

### 9.1 YouTube Channel and Video Resources

The Videha YouTube channel (www.youtube.com/@videha_ejournal) serves as the video arm of the children's literature archive. The NCERT Bhasha Sangam Maithili video (mp4), downloadable from Archive.org and linked from the kids.htm portal, is a landmark resource: it includes Maithili Sign Language (मैथिली संकेत भाषा) for the first time in Maithili history, making the language accessible to children who are hearing-impaired. The specific video at youtu.be/TebuC-lrSs8 brings Maithili children's language learning into the video format, complementing the print archive with a living, spoken, and signed presentation of the language.

### 9.2 Audio Resources: Maithili Pathshala

The three-hour Maithili-Hindi Conversation audio (mp3), compiled by Vandana Jha under the Maithili Pathshala series and archived at Archive.org, provides an audio counterpart to the text-based grammar and vocabulary resources. For children who are visually impaired, or who learn language primarily through listening, this resource is irreplaceable. The direct link provided on kids.htm (archive.org/download/maithili-hindi-conversations) ensures free, permanent access without institutional gatekeeping.

### 9.3 Script and Keyboard Resources: Digital Sovereignty

The kids.htm portal provides downloads for Tirhuta Noto font (TTF), Kaithi OTF and TTF, Newari OTF and TTF, Tirhuta offline keyboard (Malar Tirhuta.zip), and Keyman Tirhuta/Vedic Devanagari keyboards. The online Tirhuta keyboard at malarproject.gitlab.io/tirhuta ensures that children can practise writing in the classical Mithilakshara script through a web browser without any software installation.

This script infrastructure is a form of digital sovereignty: by ensuring that Tirhuta can be typed, read, and rendered on any device, the Videha project guarantees that future generations of Maithili children will have access to their classical script heritage. Gajendra Thakur's contribution of Tirhuta Unicode proposals to the Unicode Consortium — which resulted in Tirhuta receiving an official Unicode block (U+11480–U+114DF) — is the foundational technical act that makes this digital sovereignty possible.

## 10. Critical Criteria for Maithili Children's Literature: A Revised Synthesis

Drawing together Gajendra Thakur's editorial framework, the Navya-Nyāya epistemological criteria, and the Western theoretical tools surveyed above, we can formulate the following composite critical criteria:

| Criterion | Theoretical Grounding & Examples from Corpus |
|---|---|
| Epistemological Integrity | Navya-Nyāya pramāṇa theory. 'Anil's Hamrahi Khāitar (valid perceptual content); Kashyap Kamal's Sahasramukha |

| | |
|---|---|
| | Dīp (sound inferential logic correcting institutional error). |
| Aesthetic Richness | Bharata's rasa theory. 'Anil's adbhuta (wonder) and vīra (heroic-feminist); Kashyap Kamal's hāsya (comic-philosophical); Jyoti's karuṇa (pathos). |
| Developmental Appropriateness | Piaget's developmental stages; Iser's implied reader. 'Anil's dual-address poem (child and mother implied readers simultaneously). |
| Psychological Depth | Bettelheim's Uses of Enchantment. Kashyap Kamal's symbolic reversal narratives (relational vs material wealth). |
| Feminist Consciousness | bell hooks; Butler's performative speech act. 'Anil's Bucci Baṛhatī — the girl's own voice naming and defeating patriarchal structures. |
| Linguistic Fidelity | Ngũgĩ's decolonisation argument. All corpus authors maintain authentic Maithili honorifics, phonemics, and cultural vocabulary. |
| Cultural Heritage | Thakur's dharohar criterion; Propp's morphology. Kashyap Kamal's Proppian tale-structures; 'Anil's Vedic-stuti cosmological frame. |
| Folk-Oral Continuity | Navya-Nyāya śabda-pramāṇa. Both 'Anil' (poem as dialogue) and Kashyap Kamal (father-tale) activate parental transmission as āpta testimony. |
| Social Justice | Thakur's explicit criteria; postcolonial and Dalit literary theory. 'Anil's direct critique of dowry-tilak system; Videha's inclusion |

| | |
|---|---|
| | of Dalit folk heroes. |
| Multimedia Accessibility | Inclusive education theory. Videha's audio, video, Sign Language, and script resources ensure access for all children regardless of ability. |

## 11. Conclusion: The Indelible Archive

The Videha Parallel Children's Literature project represents one of the most significant systematic efforts to create, document, and theorize children's literature in any minority/classical Indian language in the 21st century. The study presented here — adding full critical accounts of Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil' and Pawan Kant Jha 'Kashyap Kamal' to the previously established framework, and integrating the audio, video, sign language, picture-book, and digital script resources of the kids.htm portal — reveals a project of extraordinary breadth, depth, and democratic commitment.

The Videha Parallel Children's Literature project represents one of the most significant systematic efforts to create, document, and theorize children's literature in any minority/classical Indian language in the 21st century. Its significance lies not only in the quality and range of texts it has assembled, but in the theoretical clarity with which its editor has articulated the critical criteria by which such a literature must be evaluated.

The Navya-Nyāya framework — indigenous to Mithila, the very heartland of the Maithili tradition — proves to be the most precise available instrument for this evaluation: it demands epistemological rigour (what kind of knowledge does the text transmit?), logical soundness (does the narrative reason well?), analogical richness (does it connect the child's world to the wider world?), and testimonial integrity (does it preserve and transmit trustworthy cultural memory?). These are not merely aesthetic criteria; they are epistemological-ethical ones, and they are inseparable from the political project of language revitalization.

The Videha Parallel History framework completes the picture: by insisting that Maithili children's literature is simultaneously ancient (pre-Vedic oral narrative) and contemporary (internet-distributed digital text), simultaneously local (the grandmother's kitchen) and global (the Maithili diaspora in Singapore, the UK, Nepal), simultaneously elite (the Sanskrit-educated editor-

critics) and folk (the anonymous grandmother who preserved the tales through ninety years of memory), the project refuses every reductive account of minority-language literature.

Jagdish Chandra Thakur 'Anil' emerges as a children's poet of the first rank: his Hamrahi Khāitar achieves the cosmological wonder that the Nāṭyaśāstra identifies as the highest aesthetic experience for the child reader, while his Bucci Baṛhatī constitutes the most powerful feminist manifesto in Maithili children's verse — naming the patriarchal structures of dowry and tilak in the girl-child's own voice, offering Kiran Bedi and Kalpana Chawla as living embodiments of the alternative. His adult work — the long poem, the ghazal collections, the autobiography — demonstrates that his children's writing is not a minor or peripheral occupation but is continuous with a major literary sensibility that operates at the highest levels of Maithili formal and philosophical ambition.

Pawan Kant Jha 'Kashyap Kamal' contributes the father-tale tradition — Bābūk Sunāel Khissā — as the masculine complement to the grandmother-tale tradition of Jyoti Sunit Chaudhary. His three tales (Sahasramukha Dīp, Jahiyāsē Kāl Dhelak, Nīk Karī Tō Paigh Ke) are philosophically rich Proppian narratives that satisfy the Navya-Nyāya criteria of sound anumāna, valid pratyakṣa, powerful dhvani, and testimonial warrant. His contribution to the Videha corpus challenges the gendering of oral cultural authority, establishing the father's voice as an equally valid āpta in the chain of literary transmission.

Gajendra Thakur's dual role — as the theoretical architect of the children's literature critical framework and as the editor-builder of the kids.htm digital ecosystem — constitutes an intellectual achievement of rare scope. The inclusion of Maithili Sign Language in the NCERT video, the Tirhuta Unicode contributions, the three-hour audio language course, the comics, and the freely downloadable library of over thirty children's titles: all of these are the expression of a single, sustained democratic vision. Preeti Thakur's comics extend this vision into the visual-narrative domain, ensuring that the Maithili literary world is open to children who learn through images before they learn through words.

The software metaphor with which Thakur concludes his foundational essay remains the most precise formulation of what is at stake: children's literature is the code that shapes the mind, and unlike a computer there is no option to format. In Mithila's own epistemological tradition, this is the recognition that

the first śabda heard is the most powerful — the grandmother's voice (Nānīk Khissā), the father's tale (Bābūk Sunāel Khissā), the poet's cosmic hymn ('Anil's Hamrahi Khāitar), the girl's manifesto (Bucci Baṛhatī) — are the first and most indelible pramāṇas. The Videha archive is the commitment that this code shall not be lost.

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Videha YouTube Channel

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ADDENDUM

**Videha Parallel Maithili Children's Literature: A Comprehensive Research and Analysis**

In the rich cultural and literary heritage of Mithila, the "Videha" movement initiated an unprecedented digital revolution in the early years of the twenty-first century. This movement is not limited to literary production alone; it is an ideological rebellion based on the philosophy of "Parallel Literature" (Samanantar Sahitya), which has bypassed traditional academic and institutional gates to provide a mainstream platform for the voices of marginalized groups—especially children, women, and Dalit communities. Videha's children's literature portal (videha.co.in/kids.htm) is a vital pillar of this movement, providing a democratic and inclusive direction for the future of Mithila through infant, child, and adolescent literature.

**The Videha Movement and the Philosophy of Parallel Literature**

The concept of parallel literature is the heart of the Videha movement. Led by Gajendra Thakur, this movement advocates for a "Parallel History of Maithili Literature," highlighting the "missing portions" of official history that were suppressed for centuries by Brahminical patriarchy and the elite class. While institutional historians used tools like "Panji Prabandh" (genealogical records) for social exclusion, the Videha movement broke social myths regarding caste purity by making the "Dooshan Panji" (The Blackbook) public.

In the context of Maithili children's literature, the parallel philosophy means providing children with literature that does not merely offer dry moral lessons but introduces them to social realities, scientific consciousness, and democratic values. Videha believes that if the Maithili language is to survive, it must become the "working language" of children, not just a "kitchen language" used at home.

**Comparative Analysis: Official vs. Parallel Tradition**

| **Aspect** | **Official/Institutional Tradition** | **Videha Parallel Literature Movement** |
|---|---|---|
| **Approa** | Elitist, centered on | Democratic, centered |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **ch** | classical dignity. | on the human heart. |
| **Eligibility** | Membership focused on Maithil Brahmins and Karna Kayasthas. | Inclusive, beyond distinctions of caste, gender, and geography. |
| **Medium** | Traditional print and academic journals. | Digital autonomy, e-journals, and open access. |
| **Objective** | Protection of established power and caste identity. | Social justice, representation of neglected voices. |
| **Language** | Sanskritized and complex vocabulary. | Simple, authentic, and scientific vocabulary. |

**Criticism and Review Methodology for Children's Literature**

The article "Shishu, Bal aa Kishor Sahitya aa Okar Samikshashastra" (Criticism of Infant, Child, and Adolescent Literature) by Gajendra Thakur provides a foundational theoretical framework for this field. The author views children's literature not just as a means of entertainment, but as a psychological tool that leaves an indelible mark on the young mind.

**Basis for Definition and Classification**

The Videha movement classifies children's literature based on age groups and cognitive development. It recognizes that a child's mental development may differ from their physical age, making "Cognitive Flexibility" essential in literature.

1. **Infant Literature (0-5 years):** Includes picture stories, lullabies, and oral tales. The role of the parent is crucial at this stage, as they help the child experience the story through images.
2. **Children's Literature (5-12 years):** Children begin to read on their own during the school-going stage. Books with short chapters and illustrated stories are effective for this group.

3. **Adolescent Literature (12-18 years):** Children's novels, science fiction, and adventurous biographies become the primary focus here.

**Key Criteria for Evaluation**

According to Gajendra Thakur, the following questions are vital for reviewing children's literature:

- Does the literature promote superstition or scientific consciousness?
- Does it help the child recognize their heritage?
- Is there any trace of casteist or ideological bigotry in it?
- Is the vocabulary simple and "Khanti" (pure) Maithili?

The author emphasizes linguistic purity, such as advising the use of 'ङ' (nga) and 'ञ' (nya) so that children become familiar with the unique sounds of their language (e.g., writing 'भाङ' instead of 'भांग').

**Structure of the Videha Children's Literature Portal (videha.co.in/kids.htm)**

The Videha children's literature portal is a "completely non-commercial and academic resource". It is not just a collection of books but a comprehensive ecosystem of various media formats.

**Description of Available Materials**

- **Folktales and Stories:** Contains a vast collection of stories heard from maternal and paternal grandmothers, such as Jyoti Sunit Chaudhary's "Nanik Khissa" and Ramlochan Thakur's "Maithili Lokkatha".
- **Illustrated Stories and Comics:** Series like "Gonu Jha aa Aan Maithili Chitrakatha" and "Natasha," compiled by Preeti Thakur, use innovative illustrations to attract children.
- **Novels and Science Fiction:** Children's novels like "Chonha" and science fiction plays like "Robot" are available for adolescents.
- **Language and Grammar:** Educational articles such as simple Maithili grammar "Maithili Subodh Vyakaran" and "Vigyanak Batkahi" are part of this portal.
- **Multidimensional Accessibility:** Audio books are available for visually impaired children, and "Sign Language" has been included in Maithili for the first time for children with hearing impairments.

**Literary and Social Analysis of Major Stories**

The stories included in Videha's collection are not merely imaginative; they are reflections of society.

**Psychological Realism: 'Chonha' (Children's Novel)**

Written by Jagdanand Jha "Manu", 'Chonha' is an invaluable heritage of modern Maithili children's literature. It is the story of a child named Sanjay who suffers from severe headaches and mental distress due to weak eyesight (myopia).

The story strikes hard at the mindset of middle-class Maithil families where a child's physical pain is often dismissed as an "excuse to avoid studies". Sanjay's mother teases him by calling him "Chonha" (squint-eyed or weak-sighted), which deeply hurts the child's self-esteem. The novel ends with Sanjay saving money himself to get glasses, after which his headaches disappear, signifying the victory of science over orthodox negligence.

**The Intersection of Science and Fantasy: 'Tarharime Pariloke'**

This novel by Gajendra Thakur is an excellent example of magical realism. The story revolves around a girl named Aastha who reaches "Fairyland" (Pariloke) through the hollow (dhodhari) of an old tree.

| Department (Color) | Responsibility in Fairyland |
|---|---|
| **Grey (Bhaterang)** | Residence and research center for scientists. |
| **Sky Blue** | Military department and security apparatus. |
| **Blue** | Educational institutions (from school to university). |
| **Green** | Botanical research (thinking plants and trees). |
| **Yellow** | Animal and human health centers. |

| | |
|---|---|
| **Orange** | Rehabilitation and mental health centers. |
| **Red** | Housing arrangements for general residents. |

The story alerts children to environmental pollution. The desert stretching beyond the "Uttarbariya Mahar" (Northern Embankment) is the result of waste thrown by the Queen's order. It teaches children that the misuse of science can be destructive.

**Revival of Tradition: 'Nanik Khissa'**

These stories, compiled by Jyoti Sunit Chaudhary, are an attempt to preserve the oral tradition. The story of "Bhalunia Mausi" shows the consequences of greed and arrogance, while "Sinnurak Pul" highlights the role of trust and loyal animals. Songs used in these stories, such as "Budhiya maiya nati suhan...", establish Maithili rhythm and meter in children's memories.

**Folk Heroes and Dalit Consciousness**

The Videha movement has re-established heroes in children's literature who were pushed to the margins by "official" literature.

| Folk Hero | Community/ Background | Significance in Parallel Literature |
|---|---|---|
| **Raja Salhesh** | Dusadh Community. | Recognition as a powerful protector and cultural symbol. |
| **Dina-Bhadri** | Musahar Community. | Inspiration for resistance and struggle against bonded labor. |
| **Lorik** | Yadava/Ahir Community. | Symbol of valor and strength, kept alive through "Lorik-nach". |
| **Bihula** | General Masses. | A universal story of female |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | | courage and devotion. |

This parallel history teaches children that heroism is not the monopoly of any particular caste; rather, every community has its own great heroes.

**Modern Genres: Bal Ghazal and Rubai**

The entry of genres like the Ghazal and Rubai into Maithili children's literature through the "Anchinhar Aakhar" movement is a significant turning point. Poets like Ashish Anchinhar and Amit Mishra have written Ghazals for children in simple meters (Bahars), demonstrating Maithili's unique phonetics while challenging the Urdu monopoly over the form.

For example, Amit Mishra's children's Ghazal "Boua hamar chhai kamoua..." presents the playfulness of the child's mind and their growing attraction to fashion in a very interesting manner.

**Maithilization of Education and Science**

Videha believes that children should receive education in rigorous science, not just imaginary stories, in their mother tongue.

- **Computer k Khel (Shabnam Shree):** This article tells children that the computer is not just a gaming machine but a powerful medium for learning. It inspires them to solve complex math and science problems through play.
- **Newton's Principles (Shambhu Nath Jha):** Difficult laws of physics are made accessible to children by casting them into Maithili verses.
- **Biography of Rahul Sankrityayan (Beauty Kumari):** Through the life of the great 20th-century scholar Rahulji, children are taught the lessons of "wandering" (Ghummakkari) and the curiosity for knowledge.

**Script, Unicode, and Digital Sovereignty**

A large part of the Videha movement is dedicated to the preservation and modernization of the "Tirhuta" (Mithilakshar) script. Gajendra Thakur transcribed 11,000 palm-leaf manuscripts and published them as "Genome Mapping".

Script-related resources available on the portal:

1. **Learn Kaithi Script:** Resources to learn the historical script used by the Kayastha community.
2. **Tirhuta Unicode Proposal:** Videha's contribution to setting standards for Maithili's own script in the Unicode Consortium.

3. **English-Maithili Computer Dictionary:** Standardization of computer terminology in Maithili.

**Social Reform and the Voice of Children**

The Videha movement does not just write literature; it is also a vehicle for social reform. According to research by Dr. Baby Kumari, social reform movements in modern Mithila have created public opinion against evils like Sati, child marriage, and untouchability. Videha's children's literature works to pass these reforms down to the next generation.

Sanskriti Verma's poem "Katae Jai..." gives voice to the pain of children confined in urban flats, who are losing their childhood amidst obscene scenes on the internet and TV. She appeals to "Nehru Chacha" to free them from the burden of heavy school bags and return their childhood of play.

**Future Challenges and Conclusion**

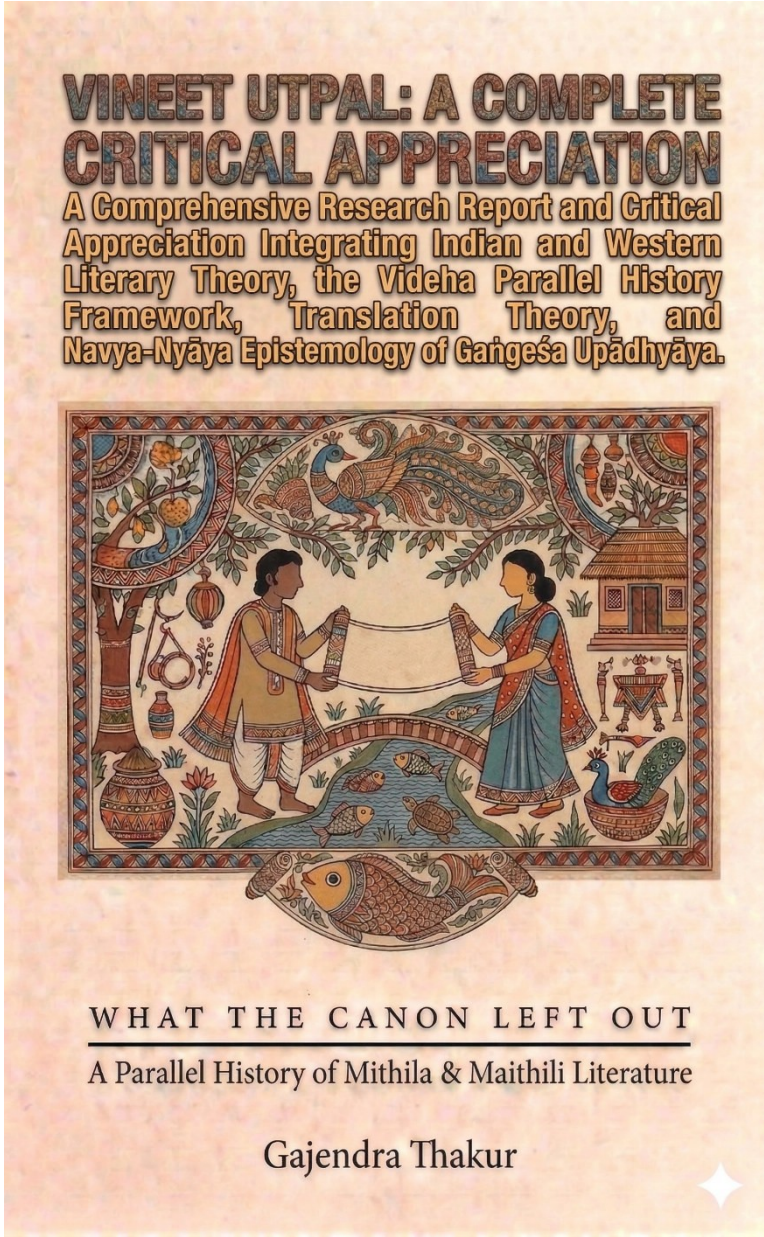
The biggest challenge facing Maithili children's literature today is displacement and a sense of linguistic inferiority. Gajendra Thakur clarifies that Maithili-speaking parents themselves are keeping their children away from Maithili, in which cartoon channels and English-medium education play a large role.

The Videha movement is constantly striving to change this trend. The "Shishu Utsav" organized by it is not just a compilation but an attempt to present Maithili children's literature as a "picnic" so that children learn to love their language.

The Videha Parallel Maithili Children's Literature movement has proven that the vitality of a language lies not in its antiquity, but in how easily it communicates with its children. From Vedic generosity to modern scientific rationalism, this digital archive of Videha is a bridge connecting the cultural dignity of Mithila with the global consciousness of the twenty-first century. If future generations feel proud of their identity, the credit will certainly go to parallel movements like Videha that are spreading the scent of Mithila's soil across the vast sky of the internet with the mantra of "Manushimih Sanskritam".

The success of the Videha movement lies in the fact that it has taken literature out of the closed shelves of academies and brought it to the fingertips (Touchscreen) of children, making Maithili not just a memory of the past but a possibility for the future.

**LESSON 098 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**



# VINEET UTPAL: A COMPLETE CRITICAL APPRECIATION

## A Comprehensive Research Report and Critical Appreciation Integrating Indian and Western Literary Theory, the Videha Parallel History Framework, Translation Theory, and Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya

**Primary works consulted:** *Hum Puchhait Chhi* (Poetry, 2009), *Mohandas* (Maithili Translation), *Rehan Par Raghu* (Maithili Translation), *Mantradrashta Rishyashringa* (Maithili Translation) - Videha Parallel History Framework (www.videha.co.in) - Indian Rasa–Dhvani Aesthetics (Bharata, Abhinavagupta, Ānandavardhana) - Western Literary Theory (New Criticism, Post-colonialism, Hermeneutics, Translation Studies) - Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (*Tattvacintāmaṇi*)

## PART I: BIOGRAPHICAL OVERVIEW AND LITERARY CONTEXT

### *1.1 Life and Formation*

Vineet Utpal (Vinīt Utpal, विनीत उत्पल), born 1978 in Anandpura, Madhepura (Bihar), represents a significant voice in contemporary Maithili literature — a poet, journalist, translator, and literary activist who emerged in the early years of the twenty-first century against the backdrop of a language and culture striving for renewed institutional recognition. His family name Utpal (lotus) carries deep Sanskrit resonance, and his life journey mirrors the socio-cultural tensions at the heart of Mithila's modernity.

His early education spanned Munger district — in Rangaon and Tarapur — before he pursued a B.Sc. (Honours) in Mathematics from Tilkamanjhi Bhagalpur University, a degree that signals the analytical, structural sensibility discernible in his literary work. He subsequently earned postgraduate diplomas from two of India's most distinguished institutions: a Master's degree in Mass Communication from Guru Jambheshwar University, and a Postgraduate Diploma in English Journalism from Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, New Delhi. He

also holds a Postgraduate Diploma in Mass Communication and Creative Writing from Jamia Millia Islamia, New Delhi, where he was additionally certified by the Nelson Mandela Centre for Peace and Conflict Resolution — a detail that illuminates the ethical, conflict-sensitive consciousness informing his poetry and journalism. He completed a French language course at Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan.

His journalistic career spans major Hindi media platforms: Dainik Bhaskar (Indore, Raipur), Delhi Press, Dainik Hindustan (New Delhi, Faridabad), Akinchan Bharat (Agra), Deshbandhu (Delhi), and National Sahara (Noida), where he rose to Senior Sub-Editor. His voice was broadcast on All India Radio Bhagalpur through poetry readings and discussions.

### *1.2 The Videha Context*

Utpal's literary career unfolds within — and is inseparable from — the Videha movement, the most significant development in contemporary Maithili literature. Videha (ISSN 2229-547X), founded as *Bhalsarik Gachh* on 5 July 2004 and relaunched as a fortnightly e-journal from 1 January 2008, is edited by Gajendra Thakur and constitutes the first Maithili fortnightly e-journal. The Videha Parallel History of Maithili Literature, which documents and celebrates the suppressed democratic, folk, Dalit, and feminist traditions of Maithili writing, explicitly names Vineet Utpal as a key figure in the RTI-based institutional exposé of the Sahitya Akademi — the Right to Information application filed by Utpal and Ashish Anchinhar (2011–2014) revealing that over 90% of Sahitya Akademi translation and publication assignments in Maithili were distributed to friends and relatives of the ten-member advisory board, with zero assignments going to authors of the parallel tradition.

This activist dimension of Utpal's career — the use of democratic legal instruments to challenge literary gatekeeping — positions him as both a creative writer and a cultural reformer, a dual identity that inflects every dimension of his literary output.

## PART II: PRIMARY WORKS — DESCRIPTION AND ANALYSIS

### *2.1 Hum Puchhait Chhi (We Are Asking), 2009*

**Publication data:** Shruti Prakashan, New Delhi. ISBN: 978-93-80538-05-1. Price Rs. 160. First Edition, 2009. Cover design: Ravindra Kumar Das.

**Dedication:** To his mother Premlata Jha and father Dr. Vedananda Jha, acknowledging that in their lap he gained the capacity to speak, read, write, and think.

This collection of Maithili poems is Utpal's most significant original creative work and the primary document through which his poetic sensibility must be assessed. The collection's title — *Hum Puchhait Chhi* (We Are Asking / I Keep Asking) — announces an interrogative poetic consciousness, one that refuses settlement and comfort, that insists on the unresolved question as the proper posture of the engaged citizen-poet.

The collection carries a substantial critical preface by Dr. Gangesh Gunjan, himself a distinguished Maithili writer, who describes the manuscript as representing "a fundamental concern of the present and the present's cry." Gunjan identifies three semantic layers (artha-chhāyā) in Utpal's poetry: the mode of utterance (*kathanaka koti*), its grip (*pakad*), and the method of its deployment (*prayogaka vidhi*). These three axes — what is said, how it seizes the reader, and through what formal means — constitute the Navya-Nyāya-inflected framework through which Gunjan reads Utpal's work.

**Thematic inventory (from the table of contents):**

24. *Kakar galti* (Whose fault) — civic accountability, systemic negligence
25. *Manukho nahin bhel* (Did not become human) — humanity's failure, caste
26. *Ki pharak padait achhi* (What difference does it make) — civic indifference
27. *Ang Desh* (The Anga Region) — regional identity, Bihar's subaltern geography
28. *Pariksha* (Examination) — educational systems, social pressure
29. *Gama dubi gael* (The village drowned) — displacement, flood, ecology
30. *Partner, ahank mool ki?* (Partner, what is your origin?) — caste identity
31. *Nahin time apna lel* (No time for oneself) — alienation, modernity
32. *Bhav-samarpan* (Emotional surrender) — lyric interiority
33. *Itihasak likhal* (Written by history) — historical consciousness

34. *Aatank* (Terror/Fear) — violence and social fear
35. *E thakak katha* (Story of this fatigue) — exhaustion of the subaltern
36. *Nokari aaki aajivan karaawas* (Job or lifelong imprisonment) — labour alienation
37. *Jati-pati* (Caste) — direct confrontation with caste
38. *Ek dhur jamin* (One dhur of land) — agrarian question, dispossession

The preface (written by Utpal himself) is a remarkable document of poetic self-awareness. He writes that the collection presents images of village conditions, the social fractures of Mithila and Anga, and the lived experience of life — and that every poem attempts to untangle those knots. He describes the birth of his poetic self as simultaneously "a slap on the face of society" — a declaration of rupture. He frames the poet's task in terms of temporal responsibility: the contemporary poet must neither inherit the past passively nor escape into an abstract future, but must transform the knowledge and experience of one's own time into aesthetically crafted, sensibility-driven utterance of lasting significance.

The section-heading of the preface to Gunjan's introduction, "Kaviak Atmokti: Kavitaak Aena" (The Poet's Self-Liberation: The Mirror of Poetry), offers a striking conceptual frame: poetry as both the poet's self-release and the mirror in which society sees its own face.

### *2.2 Mohandas — Maithili Translation of Uday Prakash's Hindi Novella*

**Translation details:** Hindi source: Uday Prakash (born 1 January 1952, Shahdol, Madhya Pradesh), *Mohandas* — a long story (*dīgha kathā*) for which Uday Prakash received the Sahitya Akademi Award 2010 (Hindi). Maithili translation: Vineet Utpal. First serialized in Videha fortnightly e-journal, Issue 74 (15 January 2011) through Issue 78 (15 March 2011) in five instalments. Later published as a standalone PDF available in Devanagari, Mithilakshar, and Braille scripts on www.videha.co.in. Subsequently published (2013) by Sahitya Akademi, New Delhi.

*Mohandas* is a devastating novella about identity theft, bureaucratic violence, and the systematic dispossession of a Dalit protagonist whose name, certificates, and very existence are appropriated by an upper-caste impostor. Utpal's choice to translate this work is itself a critical act: he brings into Maithili a Hindi text that exposes precisely the caste-based institutional corruption that Videha's RTI work was simultaneously challenging in the

Maithili literary world. The translation performs a meta-commentary on the condition of Maithili letters.

Uday Prakash's prose style is notably cinematic, hallucinatory, and elliptical — characteristics that present significant translation challenges. Utpal's Maithili rendering, opens with the evocative original's description of colour and fear: the translator mobilizes a Maithili that is simultaneously classical in its morphology and urgent in its contemporary register.

### *2.3 Rehan Par Raghu — Maithili Translation of Kashinath Singh's Hindi Story*

**Translation details:** Hindi source: Kashinath Singh, *Rehan Par Raghu* — a Sahitya Akademi Award-winning Hindi story. Kashinath Singh is known particularly for *Kashi Ka Assi* (on whose world Raghu also draws), and the translated text opens with a dedication to his "younger brother Kripashankar Chaubey." Maithili translation: Vineet Utpal.

This translation brings into Maithili a text rooted in Banaras's cultural landscape — Raghu is not just a character but a world, a way of inhabiting time and street. Utpal's Maithili must bridge the Bhojpuri-inflected Hindi of Singh's Assi ghats with the Tirhuta grammar of Mithila — a genuinely complex cultural translation operation.

### *2.4 Mantradrashta Rishyashringa (Śrutiprakashan edition) — Maithili Translation*

**Translation details:** Hindi source: Harishankar Shrivastava "Shalabh," editor Shrigopal Pandit. Subject: Rishyashringa, the Vedic sage-figure whose story appears in the Valmiki Ramayana, Mahabharata, Bhagavata, and Uttararamacharita of Bhavabhuti. The text is published by a scholarly cultural institution and concerns the Koshi region's ancient cultural heritage, a topic of profound significance for Mithila.

The editor's preface contextualizes Rishyashringa within the broader narrative of the Koshi anchal — arguing that his ashram (located in the Munger region near Shringeshwar) represents a living synthesis of Vedic, Shaiva, and folk traditions. Utpal's translation of this mythological-historical text from Hindi into Maithili extends his repertoire from contemporary social fiction to the deep temporal layer of itihasa.

# PART III: CRITICAL APPRECIATION THROUGH MULTIPLE FRAMEWORKS

## *3.1 Indian Rasa-Dhvani Aesthetics (Bharata, Ānandavardhana, Abhinavagupta)*

The foundational framework of Indian literary criticism is the rasa theory, formulated by Bharata Muni in the *Nāṭyaśāstra* (c. 200 BCE–200 CE) and theorized through dhvani (resonance) by Ānandavardhana in the *Dhvanyāloka* (c. 9th century CE), and deepened by Abhinavagupta's *Abhinavabhāratī* and *Locana*. Within this framework, the central evaluative question is: which rasa (aesthetic emotion) dominates, and how does the poem's dhvani (suggested meaning, the "soul of poetry") operate beyond its vācyārtha (expressed meaning) and lakṣyārtha (indicated meaning)?

In *Hum Puchhait Chhi*, the dominant rasa is karuṇa (pathos/compassion), inflected throughout with vīra (the heroic impulse of moral protest) and with bībhatsa (the horrific, evoked by caste discrimination and agrarian dispossession). The title poem's interrogative stance instantiates what Ānandavardhana would call *sākṣātkāri* dhvani — a resonance that makes the reader directly experience the unresolved condition of injustice rather than merely describe it.

Poem titles like "Gama dubi gael" (The village drowned) and "Ang Desh" (The Anga region) operate through what Abhinavagupta calls *rasadhvani* — where the surface image (a drowned village, a geographical name) releases an entire cultural-emotional complex: the Koshi floods, Mithila's centuries of agrarian suffering, the indifference of state power. The reader's sadāraṇīkaraṇa (universalization of the particular experience through aesthetic identification) transforms private grief into shared cultural emotion.

Utpal's poem "Partner, ahank mool ki?" (Partner, what is your origin?) performs a radical reversal of the Sanskrit śṛṅgāra (erotic/love) rasa's conventional question of origin (*kula*): in classical poetry, *kula* establishes noble lineage and worthiness of love; here it becomes an instrument of caste interrogation and social violence, instantiating what the *Nāṭyaśāstra* calls *vibhāva* (the excitant of aesthetic emotion) deployed in a context that activates karuṇa rather than the expected śṛṅgāra.

## *3.2 Western Literary Frameworks*

### 3.2.1 New Criticism and Close Reading

The New Critical tradition (I.A. Richards, William Empson, Cleanth Brooks, Robert Penn Warren) insists on the poem as autonomous verbal object whose meaning resides in its tensions, ambiguities, and ironic structures. Applied to Utpal's "Nokari aaki aajivan karaawas" (Job or lifelong imprisonment), New Critical close reading reveals a central ambiguity: the grammatical conjunction "aaki" (or) suspends the poem between two possible readings — is employment a disguised form of imprisonment, or does the poem posit an either/or choice? The irony, as Cleanth Brooks would note, is that both terms of the alternative are ultimately equivalent: modern Maithili rural life offers neither freedom nor dignity in employment. The "tension" (John Crowe Ransom's term) between the poem's surface inquiry and its deep implication is what generates its aesthetic power.

Empson's concept of *ambiguity* (from *Seven Types of Ambiguity*, 1930) is especially relevant to the title *Hum Puchhait Chhi*: the grammatical person (hum = I/We in Maithili), the tense (puchhait = habitual/continuous present of asking), and the absence of an explicit addressee create a profound ambiguity. Who is asking? The lyric "I"? The Maithili community? The poor and dispossessed? Who is being asked? The state? History? The powerful? This undecidability is not a weakness but the poem's constitutive power.

### 3.2.2 Post-Colonial Theory (Spivak, Bhabha, Fanon)

Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's foundational essay "Can the Subaltern Speak?" (1988) is directly pertinent to reading Utpal's poetry and activism. Spivak argues that the colonial and postcolonial power structure erases the enunciative position of the subaltern — not just silencing their speech but eliminating the conditions under which their speech can be heard. Utpal's poetry — written in Maithili, a language that has itself been systematically misclassified as a "dialect of Hindi" despite Grierson's and S.K. Chatterji's evidence of its distinctness — performs the subaltern's insistence on being heard in its own voice.

The RTI action (Utpal and Anchinhar, 2011–2014) can be read through Homi Bhabha's concept of *mimicry* and *sly civility* (*The Location of Culture*, 1994): the subaltern writer who uses the colonial/postcolonial state's own legal mechanisms against its institutions performs a kind of strategic mimicry that

exposes the gap between the institution's stated democratic principles and its actual caste-based distribution of resources.

Frantz Fanon's argument in *The Wretched of the Earth* (1961) about the necessity for colonized cultures to reclaim their own literary and historical narratives is structurally homologous to the Videha Parallel History project. Utpal's translation work — bringing Uday Prakash's *Mohandas* (the story of a Dalit whose identity is stolen by upper-caste usurpers) into Maithili — is precisely the kind of cultural retrieval and re-narration that Fanon theorized as necessary for decolonization of the mind.

### 3.2.3 Marxist and Materialist Criticism

György Lukács's concept of *typicality* — that great literature creates characters and situations that are *typical* in the sense of crystallizing the essential social contradictions of their historical moment — illuminates Utpal's poetry. His poems are not about individual villagers or particular floods: they construct the *typical* condition of the Maithili peasant under late capitalism and caste feudalism simultaneously. The drowned village (*Gama dubi gael*) is both a concrete, particular event (Koshi floods) and a historically typical figure for the systematic abandonment of agrarian communities by the postcolonial developmental state.

Raymond Williams's concept of *structures of feeling* (*Marxism and Literature*, 1977) — the pre-formalized, emergent dimension of social experience that literature captures before ideology codifies it — describes exactly what Utpal's poetry does. His poems register the affective texture of a Maithili life that official discourse (Sahitya Akademi awards, government cultural policy) has not yet acknowledged: the fatigue, the interrogative rage, the humour that survives dispossession.

### 3.2.4 Feminist and Gender Criticism

Elaine Showalter's *gynocriticism* and Julia Kristeva's theory of the *semiotic* (the pre-linguistic, maternal, bodily dimension of language that disrupts the symbolic order) find indirect application in Utpal's work through his sustained engagement with the women poets and writers of the Maithili parallel tradition. The Videha movement's commitment to including women's writing — as documented in the *Parallel History* and the anthology *Ijoriyak Angaithi-Mor* — is an institutional correlate of the feminist critical position that women's writing constitutes a suppressed counter-archive. Utpal's poem "Bhav-samarpan" (Emotional surrender) may be read as precisely the kind of anti-

heroic, vulnerably subjective lyric that Showalter would identify as characteristic of an alternative, non-martial poetics.

### 3.2.5 Reader-Response Theory and Hermeneutics

Hans Robert Jauss's concept of *Erwartungshorizont* (horizon of expectations, *Toward an Aesthetic of Reception*, 1970) is particularly illuminating for Utpal's translation practice. When Utpal translates *Mohandas* into Maithili, he transforms the Maithili reader's horizon of expectations in two directions simultaneously: the reader's prior knowledge of Mithila's own institutional corruption creates a local over-determination of the text's meaning that no Hindi reader can share, while the formal expectations associated with the Maithili literary tradition (*dhvani*-based suggestion, Vidyapati's lyric inheritance) reshape how the novella's ironic mode is received. Every act of translation is, in Jauss's terms, an aesthetic event that restructures the receptor culture's relationship to its own literary history.

Hans-Georg Gadamer's *hermeneutic circle* (*Truth and Method*, 1960) — the understanding of a text proceeds through the circular movement between part and whole, between the reader's prior understanding (*Vorverständnis*) and the text's own horizon — maps precisely onto the challenge of translating Kashinath Singh's Banaras-world into Maithili. Utpal as translator performs a Gadamerian *Horizontverschmelzung* (fusion of horizons): the Varanasi world of Raghu and the Mithila world of Maithili readership are brought into dialogical fusion through the translator's hermeneutic labour.

## *3.3 Translation Theory Applied to Utpal's Practice*

### 3.3.1 Eugene Nida's Formal vs. Dynamic Equivalence

Eugene Nida's fundamental distinction (*Toward a Science of Translating*, 1964) between *formal equivalence* (word-for-word fidelity to source language structure) and *dynamic equivalence* (reproducing the effect of the source text in receptor language terms) defines the fundamental tension in Utpal's translation of *Mohandas*. Uday Prakash's prose employs a deliberately defamiliarizing Hindi — dense with cinematic metaphor, interrupted syntax, and dark lyrical imagery — that resists transparent formal equivalence in Maithili. Utpal's choice to pursue dynamic equivalence means deploying specifically Maithili idioms, proverbial wisdom, and Mithilakshar-rooted affective registers to reproduce the terror, irony, and pathos of the original. The opening paragraphs

of the translated *Mohandas* demonstrate this: Utpal's Maithili captures the "colour of fear" (*darak ranga kehan hoit achhi*) through imagery that is simultaneously true to Uday Prakash and specifically Maithili in its tonal depth.

### 3.3.2 Lawrence Venuti's Domestication vs. Foreignization

Lawrence Venuti (*The Translator's Invisibility*, 1995) argues that translation occupies an ethical as well as aesthetic dimension: the *domesticating* translator erases cultural difference, making the foreign text fluent and invisible in the target culture; the *foreignizing* translator retains the strangeness of the original, challenging the target culture's assumptions.

In translating both Uday Prakash (Delhi-based, Hindi) and Kashinath Singh (Banaras, Hindi) into Maithili, Utpal performs a subtle negotiation. His translations are not domesticating in the simple sense: both source texts carry cultural particularity (Delhi's bureaucratic nightmare; Banaras's ghats and *pahalwan* culture) that cannot simply be erased. Yet his Maithili cannot be so foreign as to create unintelligibility for Maithili readers. The translated *Mohandas* operates in a productive in-between zone — what Venuti might call *strategic foreignization* — that preserves the Hindi text's specificity while finding Maithili equivalents for its emotional registers.

### 3.3.3 Antoine Berman's Ethics of Translation

Antoine Berman (*The Experience of the Foreign*, 1984/1992) argues that the true ethics of translation involves confronting the "trial of the foreign" — resisting the twelve deforming tendencies (rationalization, clarification, expansion, ennoblement, qualitative impoverishment, destruction of rhythms, etc.) that translation typically imposes on source texts. Applied to Utpal's translation of *Mantradrashta Rishyashringa*, Berman's framework illuminates the specific ethical challenge of translating a mythological-historical text: the risk of either over-Sanskritizing the Maithili (imposing a classical patina that the Hindi original's accessible prose does not warrant) or over-colloquializing (losing the ritual dignity appropriate to the itihasa subject matter). Utpal's navigation of this Bermanesque "trial" reflects a mature translator's judgment.

### 3.3.4 Walter Benjamin's "The Task of the Translator"

Walter Benjamin's mystical-philosophical essay (1923, translated and introduced by Hannah Arendt in *Illuminations*) argues that translation releases the *reine Sprache* (pure language) — the afterlife of the original, the language

that underlies all languages. Translation, for Benjamin, is not primarily about conveying meaning but about revealing, through the foreign language's syntax and imagery, the higher language that both source and target language approximate.

This framework finds unexpected resonance with the Sanskrit-derived concept of *sphoṭa* (the eternal linguistic essence that sound-sequences only approximately reveal), theorized by Bhartrhari in the *Vākyapadīya* — one of the key philosophical texts of the Mithila intellectual tradition. When Utpal translates *Mohandas* into Maithili, the Benjaminian afterlife of Uday Prakash's Hindi novella intersects with the sphoṭa-dimension of Maithili's own linguistic being: the translation reveals, momentarily, a literary essence that neither Hindi nor Maithili alone can fully express.

### *3.4 The Videha Parallel History Framework*

The Videha Parallel History framework (as articulated by Gajendra Thakur across Parts 1–53+ of the Parallel History series at www.videha.co.in) provides the most contextually appropriate critical lens for Utpal's work. This framework operates through several key methodological commitments:

**The Two-Tradition Model:** Mainstream Maithili literary history (as curated by the Sahitya Akademi) has systematically promoted an upper-caste (predominantly Maithil Brahmin) canon. The Parallel History documents the suppressed counter-tradition: Buddhist *charyapada*, Dalit and subaltern writing, women's writing, Nepal-Terai Maithili, and the democratic-satiric tradition represented by Harimohan Jha. Utpal's poetry belongs unambiguously to the Parallel tradition: socially engaged, rooted in the lives of ordinary Maithili people, formally modern rather than classicist, and institutionally marginalized before Videha created the platform for its recognition.

**RTI Activism as Literary-Political Act:** The Parallel History identifies the RTI exposé by Utpal and Anchinhar as a landmark moment in the Maithili literary struggle: an act that deployed the tools of democratic governance against the cultural bureaucracy of the postcolonial state. This mirrors the tradition of protest writing documented in the Parallel History — from Faturilal's famine verses (1873–74) to Harimohan Jha's anti-caste satire — as acts of testimony against institutional power.

**Digital Democratization:** The Videha movement's achievement of digitizing thousands of Maithili books, transcribing 11,000 palm-leaf Tirhuta manuscripts, contributing to Unicode Tirhuta, and creating the first Maithili Braille website constitutes what the Parallel History calls a "living parallel institution." Utpal's work — published first in Videha's fortnightly issues, distributed freely as PDFs across the globe — is structurally embedded in this digital-democratic project.

**Vineet Utpal in the Women's Writing Parallel:** The *Parallel History* Part 1 specifically notes that RTI data on the exclusion of women from Sahitya Akademi Maithili assignments was "confirmed by Vinit Utpal / Ashish Anchinhar (2011–14)." This places Utpal not merely as a poet but as a gender-justice advocate within Maithili letters — consonant with the feminist critical frameworks discussed above.

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## *3.5 Navya-Nyāya Epistemology and the Methodology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya*

### 3.5.1 Introduction to Navya-Nyāya

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (c. 1325 CE), born and working in Mithila, founded the Navya-Nyāya (New Logic) school through his magnum opus *Tattvacintāmaṇi* (Jewel of Reflection on Truth), revolutionizing Indian epistemology. The Videha Parallel History's recovery of the "suppressed Gangesh" — revealing through original Dooshan Panji (genealogical) records that he was of inter-caste origin, a fact concealed by establishment historians — makes Gaṅgeśa himself a figure of the Parallel tradition.

Navya-Nyāya developed a rigorous technical vocabulary (*paribhāṣā*) for the analysis of knowledge (*jñāna*), valid cognition (*pramā*), sources of valid knowledge (*pramāṇa* — perception, inference, comparison, verbal testimony), and the logical relations between cognizers, objects, and the properties attributed to them. Its key analytical tools — the concepts of *viśeṣaṇatā* (qualification), *viśeṣyatā* (the qualified), *anuyogitā* (the relation-relatum), *pratiyogitā* (the counter-relatum), and *svarūpasambandha* (intrinsic relation) — offer an unusually precise vocabulary for literary analysis.

### 3.5.2 Applying Navya-Nyāya to Utpal's Poetry

**Pramāṇa-analysis of the poetic claim:** Every poem makes implicit epistemic claims — about the world, about the poet's authority to speak, about the

reader's capacity to recognize. Applying Navya-Nyāya *pramāṇa* analysis: Utpal's poem "Jati-pati" (Caste) grounds its claims in *pratyakṣa* (perceptual testimony — the poet's direct witnessing of caste discrimination) and *śabda* (verbal testimony — the inherited knowledge of caste violence encoded in Maithili cultural memory). The poem's persuasive force derives precisely from this dual *pramāṇa* grounding: both the directly perceived and the culturally transmitted converge in the poem's utterance.

**Anumāna (inference) and the structure of poetic argument:** Navya-Nyāya's analysis of *anumāna* (inferential cognition) proceeds through the *vyāpti* (invariable concomitance) relation. In "Nokari aaki aajivan karaawas," the implicit *vyāpti* is: wherever there is modern employment in the Maithili social structure, there is loss of freedom (*parigraha*). The *pakṣa* (minor premise) is: Maithili people enter employment. The *sādhya* (thing to be proved) is: Maithili people lose freedom. The poem does not state this syllogism but performs it — its aesthetic force lies precisely in making the *vyāpti* felt before it can be analytically articulated.

**Viśeṣaṇatā (qualification) and dhvani:** Navya-Nyāya's technical analysis of how properties qualify their substrates (*dharmin*) maps onto Ānandavardhana's *dhvani* analysis with notable precision. In "Ang Desh" (The Anga Region), the property "Ang" (the historical-geographical qualifier) qualifies the land (*deśa*) in a way that generates multiple *anuyogis* (relata): the Mahabharata's Karna, the subaltern geography of eastern Bihar, the specific flood-plain ecology of the Koshi basin. The poem's *dhvani* operates through the proliferation of these *anuyogi* relations — each activated by the single qualifying property "Ang" — in a way that Navya-Nyāya's grammar of qualification (*viśeṣaṇatā*) can formally describe.

**Abhāva (absence) as a poetic category:** Navya-Nyāya's analysis of *abhāva* (absence, non-existence) as itself a genuine epistemic category — not merely the negation of presence but a positively cognizable entity — illuminates the profound absences in Utpal's poetic world. "Nahin time apna lel" (No time for oneself) is a poem of *abhāva*: the absent time, the absent self, the absent interiority of the alienated modern worker are not simply described as lacking but are made *present* through their formal absence in the poem's compressed, stripped diction. This is the literary instantiation of Navya-Nyāya's *prāgabhāva* (prior absence) — the presence of a condition before an expected entity arrives, which in the poem becomes the perpetually deferred arrival of selfhood and temporal freedom.

**Śabdapramāṇa and the authority of the translated text:** Navya-Nyāya paid particular attention to *śabdapramāṇa* (verbal testimony) — the conditions under which linguistic utterance constitutes valid knowledge. This framework is directly applicable to the ethics of translation. When Utpal translates *Mohandas* into Maithili, he claims (implicitly) that his Maithili text is a valid *śabdapramāṇa* transmission of Uday Prakash's Hindi original — that the translated text faithfully transmits the *artha* (meaning) of the source. Navya-Nyāya's analysis of *āptavākyam* (the utterance of a reliable authority) and the conditions for trustworthy testimony provides the logical framework within which the translator's authority can be evaluated.

### 3.5.3 The Suppressed Gaṅgeśa and Utpal's Position

The Videha Parallel History's recovery of Gaṅgeśa's inter-caste origins is not merely biographical anecdote but epistemological intervention. The *Tattvacintāmaṇi* — the greatest achievement of Maithili philosophical thought — was produced by a thinker whose social origins were subsequently suppressed by the Brahmin establishment. Navya-Nyāya's radical epistemological program (subjecting every claim to rigorous logical analysis, refusing to accept authority without reasoned examination) is itself subversive of the caste-hierarchical social order that claims to honour Gaṅgeśa while suppressing knowledge of his origins.

Vineet Utpal's position in Maithili letters mirrors this structure: his work — rigorous in its moral claims, structurally precise in its poetic construction, institutionally marginalized by the Sahitya Akademi establishment — follows in the tradition of Maithili intellectual dissidence that Gaṅgeśa himself represents at the philosophical level.

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## PART IV: UTPAL AS CULTURAL ACTIVIST AND LITERARY-POLITICAL AGENT

### *4.1 The RTI Intervention: Democratic Epistemology in Action*

The Right to Information (RTI) application filed by Vineet Utpal and Ashish Anchinhar (2011–2014), revealing the systematic cronyism in Sahitya Akademi Maithili assignments, is a landmark in Indian literary activism. The methodology — using the state's own transparency legislation against its cultural institutions — has Navya-Nyāya epistemological resonances: it insists

on *pramāṇa* (evidence-based valid cognition) over *āptavākya* (unchecked authority), demanding documentary proof for claims of institutional fairness.

This act of democratic epistemology — forcing the Sahitya Akademi to produce its decision-making records — parallels what the Videha Parallel History does at the historiographical level: insisting that the suppressed evidence (Dooshan Panji records about Gaṅgeśa's origins, RTI responses about appointment cronyism) must be admitted into the record. Truth, in both cases, requires the confrontation of institutional *vyabhicāra* (logical inconsistency, moral deviation) with documented fact.

### *4.2 The Poet as Sākṣī (Witness)*

In both Indian poetics and in the tradition of committed literature (Sartre's *littérature engagée*, the testimonio tradition of Latin American literature), the poet's fundamental role is that of *sākṣī* — witness to historical suffering. Utpal's biography — a journalist who traveled between Madhepura's villages, Delhi's newsrooms, and Videha's digital commons — positions him as precisely this kind of mobile, observant, testimonial consciousness.

His preface to *Hum Puchhait Chhi* states directly: the poems present *jīvanānubhavaka chhavih* (images of lived experience). This is not the aesthetic distance of the classical court poet but the engaged proximity of the *sākṣī* — the one who sees and refuses not to report what has been seen.

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## PART V: ASSESSMENT, SIGNIFICANCE, AND CONCLUSION

### *5.1 Literary Significance*

Vineet Utpal represents, within the Videha Parallel tradition of Maithili literature, a poet-translator-activist whose multiple roles are unified by a single ethical commitment: the insistence on the dignity and legibility of ordinary Maithili life against the twin oppressions of caste hierarchy and institutional gatekeeping.

His poetry in *Hum Puchhait Chhi* is formally economical, thematically urgent, and structurally precise — qualities that reflect both his journalistic training in the compression and clarity of prose and his deep awareness of Maithili's lyric inheritance from Vidyapati through the modern period. His translations

demonstrate a mature practice that engages responsibly with the ethical dimensions of cross-cultural literary transmission.

### *5.2 Place in the Parallel Tradition*

Within the Videha Parallel History framework, Utpal occupies a position analogous to those figures who are both creative writers and cultural activists: he writes poems of protest and self-examination, translates socially critical Hindi fiction into Maithili, and uses democratic legal tools to challenge literary institutions. His work is simultaneously a contribution to Maithili's literary corpus and a critical act within Maithili's ongoing struggle for recognition, democracy, and cultural justice.

### *5.3 Critical Evaluation*

The multi-framework analysis conducted in this report converges on a consistent assessment:

- **Indian rasa-dhvani aesthetics** identifies Utpal's primary registers as karuṇa and vīra, with sophisticated dhvani operation through underdetermined imagery and interrogative syntax.
- **New Critical close reading** reveals a poetry of productive ambiguity, tension, and ironic reversal.
- **Post-colonial theory** positions him as a subaltern voice that speaks from within the suppressed linguistic minority of Maithili-speaking people, using both poetry and democratic activism as tools of counter-hegemonic enunciation.
- **Translation studies** finds in his practice a sophisticated negotiation between dynamic equivalence, strategic foreignization, and the Bermanesque confrontation with the "trial of the foreign."
- **Navya-Nyāya epistemology** provides the rigorous analytical vocabulary to show how Utpal's poems constitute valid epistemic claims (*pramā*) grounded in perception (*pratyakṣa*) and testimony (*śabda*), structured through inference (*anumāna*), and resonant with the productive *abhāva* (absence) that generates their dhvani-effect.
- **The Videha Parallel History framework** situates him within the democratic, subaltern counter-tradition that constitutes the living alternative to the institutional Sahitya Akademi canon.

In sum: Vineet Utpal is a significant minor master of contemporary Maithili poetry and a distinguished translator whose contributions to the digitally democratized Videha tradition of Maithili letters deserve far wider scholarly recognition than they have hitherto received.

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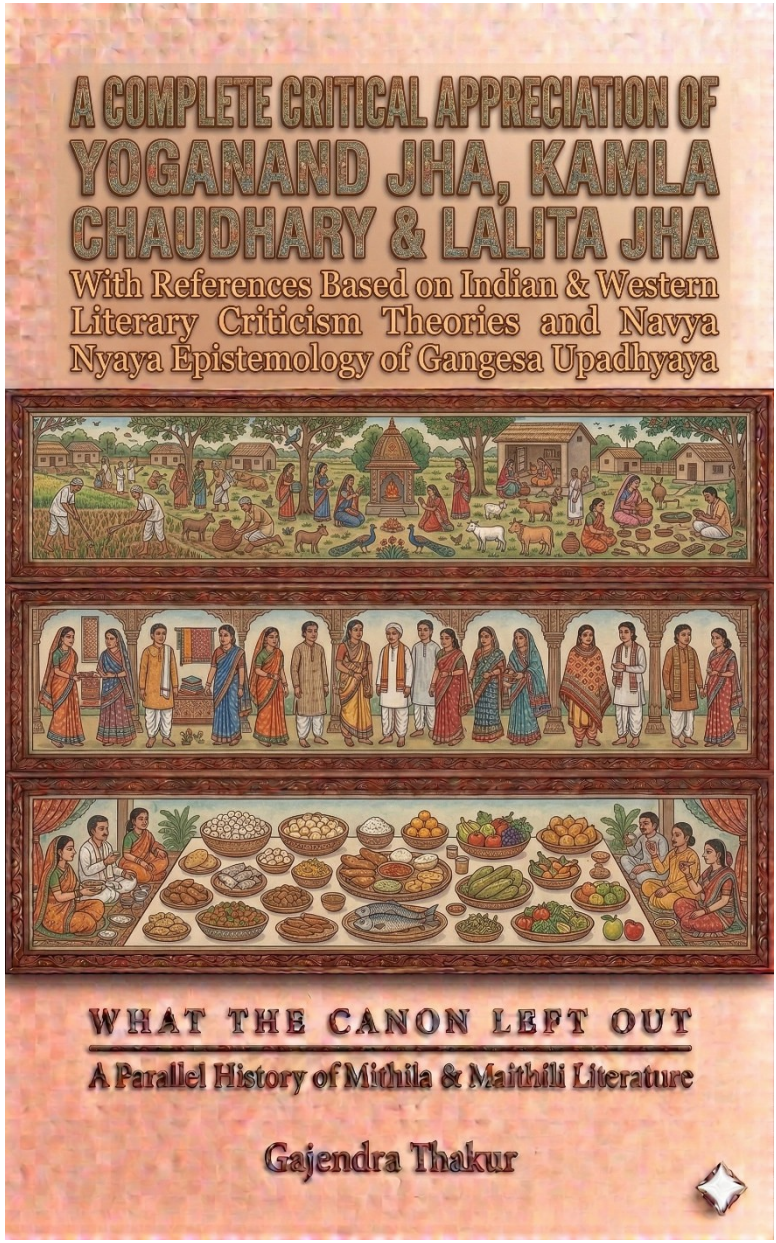
**LESSON 099 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**



# A COMPLETE CRITICAL APPRECIATION OF

# YOGANAND JHA, KAMLA CHAUDHARY

## & LALITA JHA

*With References Based on*

**Indian & Western Literary Criticism Theories**

*and*

**Navya Nyaya Epistemology of Gangesa Upadhyaya**

## Preface

The present work constitutes a critical appreciation of three significant contributors to modern Maithili literature: Yoganand Jha, Kamla Chaudhary, and Lalita Jha. Their works, published through and archived in the Videha Digital Library (www.videha.co.in/pothi.htm), represent diverse registers of Maithili literary production — fiction, folk literature, journalism, lexicography, and cultural anthropology. Together, they illuminate the vitality of the Mithila intellectual tradition in the twentieth and twenty-first centuries.

The critical framework employed in this appreciation is deliberately interdisciplinary. It draws upon Western literary theories — New Criticism, Russian Formalism, Feminist Criticism, Post-colonial Theory, and Reader-Response Theory — alongside the classical Indian aesthetic traditions of Rasa (Bharatamuni, Abhinavagupta), Dhvani (Anandavardhana), Vakrokti (Kuntaka), and Alankara (Dandin). Crucially, the analytical method also engages with the Navya Nyaya epistemological system of Gangesa Upadhyaya, the great fourteenth-century philosopher of Mithila, whose Tattvacintamani constitutes one of the foundational texts of Indian logic and whose methodology — rooted in the precise definition, delimitation, and verification of cognition-objects through the four pramanas (perception, inference, comparison, testimony) — provides a uniquely indigenous critical instrument for analysing Maithili literature.

The biographical and textual information has been drawn from primary sources (the authors' texts as archived in the Videha Library), secondary scholarship (Radha Krishna Choudhary's A Survey of Maithili Literature; Jayakant Mishra's History of Maithili Literature; Gajendra Thakur's critical writings in Videha eJournal), and contextual research on the Mithila literary tradition.

# Chapter I: Mithila, Maithili, and the Literary Tradition

## 1.1 The Civilizational Matrix of Mithila

Mithila — the ancient Videha kingdom, homeland of Janaka and Sita, bounded by the Gandaki in the west, the Kosi in the east, the Ganges in the south, and the Himalayan Terai in the north — represents one of the oldest continuing intellectual traditions in the Indian subcontinent. It is the land that produced Yajnavalkya's Brhadaranyaka Upanishad, the philosophical debates of Maitreyi, the Nyaya philosophy of Gautama, and the Navya Nyaya of Gangesa Upadhyaya. The region, corresponding roughly to the northern half of Bihar and the Terai of Nepal, became the cradle of a vernacular literary tradition in the medieval period.

Maithili, as a literary language, was inaugurated by Jyotirishwar Thakur's Varnaratnakar (c. 1324 CE) — the first prose work in any of the New Indo-Aryan languages of eastern India — and achieved its supreme lyric expression in the padas of Vidyapati (c. 1352-1448), whom Tagore described as 'a poet of happiness' and who was compared by modern scholars to Dante and Chaucer for the role he played in elevating the vernacular to a literary medium. Maithili was granted recognition by the Sahitya Akademi in 1965 and included in the Eighth Schedule of the Indian Constitution in 2003.

## 1.2 Modern Maithili Literature and the Videha Legacy

The twentieth century saw a renaissance of Maithili literary production. The emergence of modern fiction, journalism, and scholarly writing in Maithili was driven by a cluster of writers including Harimohan Jha, Upendra Nath Jha 'Vyas', Yoganand Jha, Brajkishore Verma 'Manipadma', and Rajkamal Chaudhary. Women writers and folk-literature specialists — including Kamla Chaudhary and Lalita Jha — enriched the tradition through

their attention to cultural material, social criticism, and the documentation of Mithila's living heritage.

The Videha eJournal (www.videha.co.in), founded and edited by Gajendra Thakur, has been instrumental in archiving, preserving, and disseminating this literary production. The digital archive at www.videha.co.in/pothi.htm provides open access to hundreds of Maithili texts — including the works under discussion — in PDF format, making them available to scholars globally. The Videha project consciously counters the historical marginalisation of non-Brahminical voices in Maithili literary representation, incorporating texts from multiple caste communities and genres.

## 1.3 Gangesa Upadhyaya and the Mithila Philosophical Tradition

No critical appreciation of Mithila's literary culture is complete without acknowledging the Navya Nyaya school of Gangesa Upadhyaya, the 'Great Professor' (Mahopadhyaya), who lived in Mithila in the fourteenth century and whose Tattvacintamani ('Thought-Jewel of Reality') founded the New Logic that dominated Indian philosophical discourse for the next five centuries. Gangesa's epistemological system — centred on the rigorous analysis of the four pramanas (means of valid knowledge): pratyaksa (perception), anumana (inference), upamana (comparison/analogy), and sabda (testimony/verbal authority) — and his concept of avacchedakatva (delimitation or qualification) provide a powerful analytical framework that is native to Mithila.

Gangesa's method involves: (a) the precise identification and naming of the object of cognition; (b) the identification of its distinguishing characteristic (laksana); (c) verification through the appropriate pramana; and (d) the rejection of false cognitions through rigorous definition. When applied to literary criticism, this framework demands that we ask: What exactly is the object of literary cognition? How is it perceived (pratyaksa), inferred (anumana), analogised (upamana), or received through the text's testimony (sabda)? How do we delimit (avacchedaka) the literary significance of a text from its mere grammatical or lexical surface?

This framework will be systematically applied in the analysis of each author below, alongside Western and Indian classical critical theories.

# Chapter II: Critical Appreciation of Yoganand Jha

## 2.1 Biographical and Contextual Overview

Yoganand Jha stands as one of the most versatile and prolific contributors to twentieth-century Maithili literature. A scholar of remarkable range, he worked across the genres of fiction, folk literature, poetry, journalism, cultural lexicography, Shakta studies, and social criticism. Professor Radha Krishna Choudhary, in his authoritative A Survey of Maithili Literature, places Yoganand Jha among the most significant fiction writers of the mid-twentieth century alongside Kumar Ganganand Singh, Upendra Jha 'Vyas', Shailendra Mohan Jha, and Brajkishore Verma 'Manipadma'. His novel Bhalamanusa (1944) is particularly noted as a landmark work addressing the social problems connected with the institution of marriage in Mithila society.

The corpus archived in the Videha Digital Library represents the breadth of Jha's scholarly and creative output. The twelve texts available span occupational vocabulary, folk culture, critical essays, devotional poetry, oral narrative, folk literature heritage, prose poetry, mythological drama, journalism, devotional songbooks, novel-writing, and Shakta literary tradition. Together they constitute a lifetime of literary and scholarly engagement with the Maithili language, Mithila's living culture, and its intellectual inheritance.

## 2.2 Survey of Major Works

### *2.2.1 Jatiya Vyavasaya Shabdavali (Occupational Vocabulary of Castes)*

This substantial lexicographical work of 209 pages documents the technical and occupational vocabulary specific to the various jati (caste/occupational community) groups of Mithila. It is a work of cultural linguistics and social anthropology as much as lexicography. Each occupational community — weavers, potters, carpenters, fishermen, cultivators, and others — has developed a specialised vocabulary that constitutes both a technical register and a repository of cultural knowledge embedded in the practice of livelihood.

From the perspective of Navya Nyaya epistemology, this work operates through the pramana of sabda — verbal testimony — systematically gathering and validating the lexical testimony of living occupational traditions. Gangesa's method of precise definition (laksana) and delimitation

(avacchedaka) is structurally homologous to lexicographical method: each term is isolated, its defining characteristic identified, and its appropriate usage verified. Jha's lexicographic practice thus enacts a vernacular Navya Nyaya of language documentation.

From the perspective of Western ethnolinguistics and the sociology of knowledge, this work anticipates the concerns of sociolinguistics (William Labov's work on socially stratified language variation) and ethnography of communication. It documents what anthropologists call 'domain-specific' or 'register' vocabulary — language tied to particular social practices and knowledge communities. The text is thus simultaneously an act of linguistic preservation, cultural documentation, and implicit social critique, insofar as it dignifies the technical knowledge of subaltern occupational communities by treating their language with the same scholarly rigour normally reserved for Sanskrit or classical learning.

### *2.2.2 Lokjivan aur Loksahitya (Folk Life and Folk Literature)*

This 77-page scholarly work is Yoganand Jha's systematic engagement with the folk tradition — the oral culture, custom, song, narrative, and ritual practice that forms the living substrate of Mithila's cultural identity. The distinction implied in the title — between Lokjivan (the lived experience of folk life) and Loksahitya (the literary or aesthetic production that emerges from it) — reflects the author's awareness of the dialectical relationship between culture as lived practice and culture as aesthetic expression.

In Indian aesthetic theory, the concept of loka (the world, the people, lived experience) is central. Bharatamuni's Natyashastra posits that art imitates and transforms the lokasvabhava (the natural behaviours of the world). The folk tradition represents the most unmediated expression of lokasvabhava — the songs, tales, and customs that arise from immediate experience before the mediation of formal aesthetics. Anandavardhana's theory of Dhvani (resonance or suggestion) is particularly relevant here: folk literature works through multiple layers of suggestion, where the surface narrative or lyric carries layers of cultural, mythological, and emotional meaning that resonate in the consciousness of the community listener.

Applied through the Navya Nyaya framework, Jha's text can be analysed as an exercise in what Gangesa would call anuvyavasaya — the 'after-cognition' or meta-cognition that follows and examines a primary experience. The folk literature is the primary pramana; Jha's scholarly analysis constitutes

the anuvyavasaya that critically examines, delimits, and verifies the nature of that primary cultural knowledge.

From the Western perspective, Jha's project aligns with the Romantic valorisation of folk culture (Herder's Volksgeist, the Brothers Grimm's project of national folklore collection) and the later academic institutionalisation of folklore studies. However, Jha's approach is less nationalistic and more ethnographic — it documents the specificity of Maithili folk culture rather than subsuming it into a generalised nationalist narrative.

### *2.2.3 Aalekh Sanchayan (Collected Essays)*

The 57-page collection of essays represents Yoganand Jha as a critical and reflective prose writer. The essay (aalekh) as a genre occupies an important place in modern Maithili literature — it is the form in which writers engage with literary, social, cultural, and philosophical questions in an exploratory and often personal mode. Jha's collected essays demonstrate his capacity for critical analysis, discursive prose, and engagement with questions relevant to Maithili culture and literature.

The essay tradition in India has deep roots — from the philosophical dialogues of the Upanishads and the analytical prose of Kautilya's Arthashastra to the modern critical essay that emerged under the influence of English education and journalism. In the context of Maithili, the essay is one of the more recently developed genres, and practitioners like Yoganand Jha, Harimohan Jha, and Ramanath Jha helped establish its conventions and range.

From the perspective of Western literary theory, the essay as a form has been theorised by writers from Montaigne to Theodor Adorno. Adorno's conception of the essay as a form that refuses systematic closure — that proceeds by association, digression, and the exploration of contradictions rather than by deductive argument — is particularly relevant to the Maithili essay tradition, which tends to be exploratory, anecdotal, and culturally embedded rather than formally argumentative.

### *2.2.4 Gahbar Geet (Songs of the Deep Forest)*

This slim but significant 10-page collection of verse represents Yoganand Jha's poetic voice. The title Gahbar Geet — songs of the dense forest, or perhaps songs of depth and mystery — evokes a tradition of nature poetry and mystical or devotional lyric that has deep roots in Maithili poetry from Vidyapati onwards. The geet (song) form in Maithili is not merely a literary

genre but a performative and communal one — songs are sung at festivals, in the home, in ritual contexts, and as expressions of seasonal change.

Vidyapati's foundational role in the Maithili lyric tradition makes any subsequent Maithili poetry in the geet form engage, consciously or unconsciously, with his shadow. The rasa theory of Bharatamuni and Abhinavagupta is directly applicable here: the dominant rasa of the Gahbar Geet, if its imagery of dense forest and depth is read symbolically, might be the interplay of shringara (erotic or devotional longing), karuna (pathos), and shanta (tranquility) — the rasas most associated with Maithili lyric from the medieval tradition onwards.

From a Western Formalist perspective (Russian Formalism, New Criticism), the distinguishing feature (or 'literariness', Jakobson's literaturnost) of poetry as against prose lies in its foregrounding of the poetic function of language — the way sound, rhythm, metaphor, and formal constraint generate meaning beyond the referential. In Gahbar Geet, the formal choices of metre, rhyme, and imagistic compression would be the primary objects of analysis.

### *2.2.5 Katha-Lokkatha (Stories and Folktales)*

This 50-page collection brings together both authored short stories (katha) and folktales (lokkatha) — a deliberate juxtaposition that reflects Jha's awareness of the relationship between the literary and the oral, the authored and the traditional. The inclusion of both genres in a single volume makes a critical statement: that the line between authored fiction and oral tradition is permeable, that the short story as a modern Maithili form has deep roots in the narrative heritage of oral tradition.

Yogendra Pathak Viyogi, in his Folktales of Mithila (2021), explicitly acknowledges his debt to the compilations of Yoganand Jha and Lalita Jha as foundational sources for the Mithila folktale tradition, demonstrating the scholarly significance of Jha's folkloric documentation for subsequent researchers and translators.

Narratologically (applying Gerard Genette's framework), the folktale operates through a fundamentally different narrative time and mood from the modern short story: its narrative time is the eternal present of myth, its mood is the indicative of collective truth rather than the conditional of individual experience. Jha's juxtaposition of katha and lokkatha in a single collection thus enacts a narratological dialogue between modernity and tradition.

### *2.2.6 Shabd-Lok Sahitya Sampada (Lexical Heritage of Folk Literature)*

At 71 pages, this work represents Jha's sustained engagement with the vocabulary — both in the narrow lexicographic sense and in the broader cultural sense — of the folk literary tradition. The compound title Shabd-Lok Sahitya Sampada (literally: Word-World Literary Heritage) suggests the author's understanding that the vocabulary of a literary tradition is not merely a tool but a heritage — a repository of cultural values, historical memory, and aesthetic sensibility embedded in specific lexical choices.

This text has particular significance when viewed through the Navya Nyaya epistemological framework. Gangesa's analysis of sabda-pramana (verbal testimony as a means of valid knowledge) is directly relevant: for Gangesa, the validity of verbal testimony depends on the trustworthiness of the speaker (aptavakya) and the precision of the word-meaning relationship (sabda-artha-sambandha). Jha's lexicological project is an investigation of the reliability and richness of folk literary testimony — an assessment of the cultural pramana embodied in traditional vocabulary.

### *2.2.7 Bhore Bhor (Dawn of Dawns)*

This 14-page text — the title evokes the moment of dawn, the threshold between night and day — appears to belong to the prose-poem or lyric-essay tradition. The liminal imagery of dawn has profound resonance in Maithili culture, where the Bhatiyali and other dawn-songs (usah-geet) constitute a distinct musical and poetic tradition. In the cosmological imagination of Mithila, dawn is the time of Brahma — the moment of creative potentiality before the differentiated world asserts itself.

From Abhinavagupta's perspective in the Abhinavabharati, the aesthetic experience of such liminal states produces what he calls camatkara — wonder or aesthetic flash — which is the hallmark of genuine artistic experience. The brevity of Bhore Bhor (14 pages) suggests a text of lyric intensity rather than discursive argument.

### *2.2.8 Sitavataran (The Descent of Sita)*

This 26-page text engages with one of the most charged mythological subjects in the Maithili tradition: Sita, who is the daughter of King Janaka of Mithila, born from the earth in the Maithili mythological imagination. No figure in Maithili cultural identity carries more weight than Sita — she is the supreme emblem of Mithila's civilizational pride, and her story has generated a rich counter-tradition of critical and sympathetic reinterpretation.

The title Sitavataran (the descent or incarnation of Sita) suggests a text that engages with Sita's birth and earthly arrival — her emergence from the furrow, the ritual ploughing that reveals her to Janaka. This is, in the mythology, an act of cosmic emergence: Sita is Earth's daughter, svayambhu, self-born. The text thus enters into one of Mithila's most resonant mythological narratives.

From a feminist critical perspective (following the insights of Madhu Kishwar, Nabaneeta Dev Sen, and other critics who have engaged with Sita's story), the treatment of Sita in post-Valmiki literature is never innocent — it always negotiates between the celebration of Sita's strength and the cultural structures that constrain her. 2.2.9 Maithili Patrakarita (Maithili Journalism)

This 34-page work on Maithili journalism is a contribution to the meta-critical and historical understanding of Maithili's public sphere. The history of Maithili journalism — from Maithil Hit Sadhana (1905) through the numerous journals and newspapers of the twentieth century to the Videha eJournal in the digital age — is the history of Maithili's struggle for public recognition and institutional space.

Yoganand Jha's engagement with the history and practice of Maithili journalism connects the literary to the political in a way that resonates with post-colonial theory's analysis of the 'print-capitalism' (Benedict Anderson) that underlies the formation of language communities and national consciousness. The Maithili press was not merely a vehicle for literary production; it was, as in many colonial and post-colonial contexts, an instrument of language politics and cultural assertion.

### *2.2.10 Mangal Prabhat (Auspicious Dawn)*

This 37-page text — the title combining the sacred (mangal, auspiciousness) with the natural (prabhat, dawn) — appears to be a devotional or lyrico-spiritual work. In Mithila, the concept of mangal is deeply embedded in ritual practice: mangal-geet (auspicious songs) are sung at weddings, births, and other life-cycle ceremonies. The mangal tradition connects the literary to the liturgical in a way that resonates with Bharatamuni's understanding of the origin of art in ritual performance.

### *2.2.11 Sankalp (Resolution/Vow)*

At 164 pages, Sankalp is the most substantial of Yoganand Jha's texts in the Videha archive. The title — 'resolution' or 'vow', from the Sanskrit sankalpa, which denotes a solemn mental resolve — suggests a work of major thematic ambition. In Hindu philosophical tradition, the sankalpa is the

beginning of all intentional action: before any ritual or significant undertaking, one states one's sankalpa — the identity of the actor, the time, the place, and the intention.

Whether Sankalp is a novel, a long narrative prose work, or a collection of extended essays requires direct textual access, but its length suggests a work of the scope of a novel or an extended prose narrative. Given Jha's established credentials as a novelist (evidenced by the noted Bhalamanusa of 1944), Sankalp may represent his major fictional achievement archived in the Videha collection.

From the perspective of Russian Formalist theory (Victor Shklovsky's concept of ostranenie or defamiliarisation), the novel as a form 'makes strange' the ordinary — it takes the familiar world and presents it through a narrative frame that disrupts habitual perception. The sankalpa — the solemn resolve — as a narrative frame would defamiliarise ordinary social life by subjecting it to the scrutiny of a committed moral or social intention. This is consonant with the social-realist fiction of mid-twentieth century Maithili, which engaged critically with marriage customs, caste hierarchy, and social reform.

### *2.2.12 Shakt Sahitya (Shakta Literature)*

This 38-page work engages with the Shakta literary tradition of Mithila — the devotional and philosophical literature centred on the worship of Shakti (the Divine Feminine) in her various forms. Mithila has a rich Shakta tradition: the goddess Ugratara of Mahishi, the Kamakhya cult in the broader region, and the integration of Tantra and Nyaya philosophy that characterised Mithila's intellectual tradition. Figures like Mahendranath Jha and others contributed to Shakta philosophical and devotional literature in Maithili.

The Shakta tradition complicates any simple feminist reading: Shakti worship simultaneously elevates the feminine to cosmic status and, in certain Tantric formulations, objectifies the female body as a ritual instrument. The philosophical tradition of Shakta non-dualism (Trika, Kashmir Shaivism, and related schools) provides a sophisticated account of consciousness, power, and liberation. Yoganand Jha's engagement with this tradition reflects his awareness of the depth and complexity of Mithila's intellectual heritage.

From the Navya Nyaya perspective, the analysis of Shakta literature raises the question of the pramana-status of religious and devotional experience: is the devotional experience (bhakti-anubhava) a legitimate form of knowledge? Gangesa's epistemology, focused on the four pramanas, is agnostic about the epistemic status of religious experience per se, but the Nyaya tradition

more broadly has defended the pramana-status of agamic (revealed) testimony (agama) — which would include the Shakta Tantras — as a form of valid sabda.

## 2.3 Thematic Coherence and Critical Assessment

Across Yoganand Jha's twelve archived works, several thematic and methodological threads connect the diverse genres. First, there is a consistent commitment to the documentation and elevation of Maithili cultural heritage — from the technical vocabulary of occupational communities to the oral narratives of the folk tradition to the philosophical richness of the Shakta literary heritage. This is a fundamentally preservationist and culturally affirmative project, consonant with what post-colonial scholars call 'decolonisation of knowledge' — the recovery and validation of indigenous knowledge systems marginalised by colonial and post-colonial cultural hierarchies.

Second, there is a dialectic between tradition and modernity that runs through Jha's work. His engagement with the modern novel form (Bhalamanusa, Sankalp), journalism (Maithili Patrakarita), and critical essay (Aalekh Sanchayan) places him firmly in the modernist project of Maithili literature, while his folk literature scholarship, mythological texts, and devotional poetry connect him to the deep roots of the tradition.

Third, Jha's work demonstrates a social conscience that is characteristic of the best mid-twentieth century Maithili fiction. The engagement with social problems of marriage (Bhalamanusa), the documentation of subaltern occupational vocabulary (Jatiya Vyavasaya Shabdavali), and the recovery of folk culture from elite neglect all reflect a commitment to the social function of literature and scholarship.

Applying Gangesa's epistemological framework to Jha's oeuvre as a whole, we may say that his work constitutes a multi-pramana investigation of Maithili cultural reality: pratyaksa (direct perception and lived experience) informs his fiction and folk literature; anumana (inference) informs his critical essays and journalism; upamana (analogy/comparison) informs his lexicographical work, which establishes the semantic relationships between terms; and sabda (verbal testimony) is the fundamental pramana of both his folkloric collections and his Shakta literary studies.

# Chapter III: Critical Appreciation of Kamla Chaudhary

## 3.1 Biographical and Contextual Overview

Kamla Chaudhary is a significant contributor to modern Maithili literature, represented in the Videha archive by three substantial works that span cultural anthropology, temporal meditation, and material culture. Her works demonstrate a scholar-writer who combines rigorous documentation of Maithili cultural practice with reflective and critical analysis.

The three texts archived in the Videha Digital Library — Monak Pauti (90 pages), Samay Sanket (57 pages), and Vesh Bhusha (196 pages) — collectively amount to 343 pages of sustained scholarly and literary engagement with Maithili culture. Their thematic range — from temporal markers and cultural signs to the rich material culture of dress and adornment — reflects a sensibility shaped by both literary and anthropological concerns.

## 3.2 Survey of Major Works

### *3.2.1 Monak Pauti (The Coral Bead / Symbol of the Married Woman)*

Monak Pauti (90 pages) engages with one of the most culturally charged objects in Maithili women's lives: the monak (coral) pauti (string or ornament) worn by married women as a marker of suhag (the auspicious state of having a living husband). In Mithila, the ornamental vocabulary of married womanhood — the sindur (vermilion), the pag (headband), the monak pauti — constitutes a semiotic system of remarkable complexity, encoding status, identity, devotion, and social belonging in material objects worn on the body.

From a semiotic perspective (following Roland Barthes' Mythologies and The Fashion System), the monak pauti functions as what Barthes would call a 'sign' that operates at multiple levels: at the level of denotation, it is a string of coral beads; at the level of connotation, it is a sign of marital status; at the level of myth (in Barthes' technical sense), it naturalises the ideological claim that a woman's social identity is fundamentally defined by her relationship to her husband. The critical examination of this mythological dimension — the questioning of what appears 'natural' in the semiotic system of Maithili women's ornament — is implicitly feminist in its implications.

From the perspective of Kuntaka's Vakrokti theory — the theory that literary excellence lies in 'oblique expression' or the creative deviation from

ordinary usage — the pauti as a literary symbol represents exactly the kind of vakra (oblique, non-straightforward) signification that transforms a material object into a site of cultural meaning. The literary treatment of the monak pauti would be evaluated by Kuntaka in terms of how creatively and non-obviously the material object is transformed into a carrier of cultural and emotional significance.

Through the Navya Nyaya framework, the monak pauti presents itself as a study in upamana-pramana: the analogy or comparison through which the material object is understood through its resemblance to and difference from other signs in the cultural system. Gangesa's analysis of the structure of qualification (viseshana-visheshya-bhava) — the relationship between a qualified subject and its qualifying attribute — is directly applicable: the married woman (visheshya, the qualified subject) is qualified (viseshana) by the monak pauti, and this qualification is not merely physical but social, metaphysical, and ideological.

### *3.2.2 Samay Sanket (Signs/Signals of Time)*

Samay Sanket (57 pages) — the title translating as 'signs of time', 'temporal signals', or 'time's indications' — appears to engage with the Maithili understanding of time, temporal markers, and the ways in which time is culturally encoded and experienced in Mithila society. The compound sanket (sign, signal, gesture, indication) is particularly rich: it suggests that time is not merely a neutral medium but a cultural language, a system of signs that encodes meaning for those who know how to read them.

In Indian philosophical tradition, time (kala) has been theorised in multiple frameworks — from the Nyaya-Vaisheshika tradition (which treats time as a single, infinite, self-sufficient substance) to the Buddhist tradition (which analyses time as a series of momentary events without underlying substance) to the Puranic tradition (which constructs elaborate cyclical time-schemes — yugas, kalpas, manvantaras — encoding cosmological and moral meanings in temporal structures). The Maithili folk tradition has its own rich temporal vocabulary: seasons (ritu), festivals (utsav), agricultural cycles (krishi-kala), and life-cycle stages (ashrama) all constitute a cultural time-system that differs significantly from the abstract, homogeneous time of modern industrial society.

From a cultural-studies perspective (following E.P. Thompson's analysis of time-discipline and work-culture), the encoding of time in cultural signs — the recognition of the harvest season by the appearance of certain

flowers, the identification of a festival by the sounds of particular instruments, the measurement of the year by the sequence of vratas (religious observances) — represents an alternative temporality to the commodified time of the clock and the calendar. Kamla Chaudhary's Samay Sanket may be read as a recovery and documentation of this alternative temporality.

Gangesa's epistemological analysis of time is relevant here: in the Navya Nyaya system, temporal qualification (kala-avacchedaka) is one of the key analytical tools for specifying cognition. Every cognitive event occurs at a particular time, and the delimitation of the temporal scope of a cognition is essential to its precise determination. Chaudhary's Samay Sanket can be read as a literary-cultural exploration of precisely this question: how does a culture delimit, specify, and experience its temporal location?

### *3.2.3 Vesh Bhusha (Dress and Adornment)*

At 196 pages, Vesh Bhusha is Kamla Chaudhary's most substantial work in the Videha archive and one of the most important texts on Maithili material culture available. The title — Vesh (dress, clothing, costume, appearance) and Bhusha (adornment, ornament, decoration) — encompasses the full range of Maithili sartorial and ornamental practice, which constitutes one of the richest and most regionally distinctive material traditions in India.

The material culture of dress in Mithila is extraordinarily complex and culturally specific. The Maithili sari tradition — with its distinctive styles, weaving patterns, and wearing modes — the elaborate ornamental system for women (different ornaments for different body parts, different occasions, and different stages of life), the male dress codes that mark caste, occasion, and status — all constitute a semiotic system of remarkable depth. The Maithili painting tradition (Madhubani/Mithila painting) itself frequently depicts these dress and ornament traditions, suggesting their centrality to Mithila's self-representation.

From the perspective of feminist material culture studies (following Elizabeth Wilson's Adorned in Dreams: Fashion and Modernity and Anne Hollander's Sex and Suits), dress and adornment are not merely functional but ideological: they encode and reproduce social hierarchies, gender norms, and cultural values. The study of Maithili Vesh Bhusha is thus inevitably a study of the social structures within which Maithili women and men navigate identity, status, and belonging.

From the Rasa perspective, the vesh-bhusha tradition is directly connected to the abhinaya (expressive performance) dimension of classical

Indian aesthetics. In Bharatamuni's Natyashastra, the angika-abhinaya (body-expressive dimension of performance) encompasses costume and ornament as essential components of aesthetic communication. The visual aesthetics of Maithili dress and adornment thus function as a non-verbal aesthetic language — a visual rasa-system that expresses and evokes emotional states through colour, form, material, and pattern.

The application of Gangesa's Navya Nyaya framework to Vesh Bhusha is particularly illuminating: dress and adornment constitute a system of vishesha (qualification or distinction) — each garment and ornament functions as a viseshana (qualifier) that qualifies the person who wears it. The wearing of a particular ornament 'says' something specific about the wearer's identity, status, and social position. This is precisely the structure of Navya Nyaya qualificative cognition: the cognition of a qualified complex (vishishta-jnana) involves the simultaneous awareness of a subject and its qualifying attribute in a specific relational structure.

## 3.3 Thematic Coherence and Critical Assessment

Kamla Chaudhary's three works together constitute an exploration of the semiotics of Maithili women's lives — the material objects (monak pauti, vesh-bhusha) that mark identity and status, and the temporal structures (samay sanket) that organise cultural experience. Her scholarly approach combines the rigour of cultural documentation with the sensitivity of an insider who understands the living significance of these traditions for Maithili women.

From a feminist critical perspective, Chaudhary's work occupies an ambivalent but productive position: it documents and, in documenting, implicitly valorises the material culture of Maithili women's lives, giving scholarly weight and dignity to practices that have been dismissed as 'mere custom' or 'superstition' by modernising discourses. At the same time, the analytical dimension of her work — particularly in the treatment of the monak pauti as a semiotic object — opens the space for critical examination of the gender ideologies embedded in these practices.

Applied through the Dhvani theory of Anandavardhana, Chaudhary's works can be understood as engaged in the recovery of the 'suggested meaning' (vyanjana-artha) of cultural practices that have been reduced to their surface denotation by cultural standardisation and modernisation. The monak pauti 'says' more than 'this woman is married'; the samay sanket encodes a cosmological vision; the vesh-bhusha tradition carries a complete cultural grammar. Chaudhary's scholarship makes these suggestions audible.

# Chapter IV: Critical Appreciation of Lalita Jha

## 4.1 Biographical and Contextual Overview

Lalita Jha is a scholar of Maithili folk culture whose work has been foundational for the documentation and transmission of the Mithila oral tradition. Her significance as a compiler of Maithili folktales is explicitly acknowledged by subsequent scholars: Yogendra Pathak Viyogi, in his Folktales of Mithila (2021; published on Scribd/Everand), states that he has 'benefitted from the compilations by Ram Lochan Thakur, Yoganand Jha, Lalita Jha (all in Maithili) and by Vibha Rani (in Hindi)' in preparing his English-language collection. This acknowledgement places Lalita Jha in the first rank of Maithili folktale documenters, alongside the acknowledged master Yoganand Jha.

The single work archived in the Videha Digital Library — Maithilik Bhojan Sambandhi Sabdavali represents a focused and substantial contribution to the lexicography of Maithili food culture. While this is the only text accessible in the current archive, Lalita Jha's broader contribution to Mithila folktale documentation (referenced by Viyogi) suggests a wider body of work that merits consideration.

## 4.2 Analysis of Maithilik Bhojan Sambandhi Sabdavali

### *4.2.1 Description and Scope*

Maithilik Bhojan Sambandhi Sabdavali (Vocabulary Connected with Maithili Food) is a lexicographical work documenting the rich and region-specific vocabulary of food, cooking, eating, and the related material culture in Mithila. The scope of 'bhojan sambandhi' (food-related) vocabulary is extraordinarily wide: it encompasses the names of ingredients (grains, pulses, vegetables, spices, dairy products, and their regional varieties and variants), cooking processes (the specialised vocabulary of different cooking methods, vessel types, fuel types, and kitchen practices), prepared dishes (with their regional names and variants), dining and serving customs, fasting and feasting vocabulary, ritual food (naivedya, offerings to deities), and the vocabulary of taste (rasa, svada) and food-related sensation.

Mithila's food culture is one of the most distinctive in India, characterised by its specific combinations, its ritual food traditions, its seasonal

and festival-specific preparations, and its engagement with Brahminical purity codes alongside folk and subaltern food practices. The Maithili kitchen is simultaneously a site of cultural production, religious observance, social distinction, and aesthetic pleasure.

### *4.2.2 Lexicographic Methodology and Cultural Significance*

Lalita Jha's lexicographic methodology in Maithilik Bhojan Sambandhi Sabdavali involves the systematic documentation of food-related terms, their definitions, their usage in context, and their relationship to cultural practice. This is not merely a dictionary of food terms but a cultural encyclopaedia of Mithila's food heritage — a document that preserves vocabulary at risk of loss through modernisation, urbanisation, and the homogenisation of food culture.

The cultural significance of this work is immense. Food vocabulary constitutes what anthropologist Claude Levi-Strauss called a 'culinary grammar' — a system of transformations (raw/cooked, natural/cultural, sacred/profane) that encode a culture's deepest categories. Levi-Strauss's structural analysis of food traditions in The Raw and the Cooked (1964) suggests that what a culture cooks and how it cooks reveals its fundamental cognitive and social structures. Lalita Jha's vocabulary work can be read as providing the raw material for precisely such a structural analysis of Maithili culture.

From the Navya Nyaya perspective, this lexicographic work is a sustained exercise in what Gangesa calls svalaksana-jnana — the precise cognition of particular objects in their specific individuality, as opposed to the samanya-jnana (knowledge of universals or generalities). Each food term documented by Lalita Jha is a particular (vishesha) within the general category (samanya) of food vocabulary; the precise definition and documentation of each particular is exactly the kind of analytical work that Navya Nyaya demands of any serious cognitive project.

The pramana most relevant to Jha's lexicographic project is pratyaksa (perception) combined with sabda (verbal testimony). The vocabulary is gathered through the direct observation of food practices (pratyaksa) and through the verbal testimony of practitioners, cooks, and knowledgeable community members (sabda). The verification of each term's usage involves what Gangesa calls vyapti-graha — the grasping of the invariable concomitance between a word and its referent — which is the epistemological foundation of lexicographic authority.

### *4.2.3 Food as Literary and Aesthetic Category*

Beyond its lexicographic significance, Maithilik Bhojan Sambandhi Sabdavali participates in the broader cultural project of treating food as an aesthetic and literary category. In the Indian aesthetic tradition, the rasa-system itself uses food as its foundational metaphor: rasa means both 'essence, flavour, taste' and 'aesthetic experience'. The eight (or nine) rasas of classical aesthetics — shringara (erotic love), hasya (humour), karuna (pathos), raudra (fury), vira (heroism), bhayanaka (terror), bibhatsa (disgust), adbhuta (wonder), and shanta (tranquility) — are figured as different 'flavours' of aesthetic experience, analogous to the different tastes (sweet, sour, bitter, pungent, astringent, salty) of food. The rasas are 'tasted' (rasana) by the sahridaya (the connoisseur, literally 'person with a heart'). Bharatamuni's foundational metaphor thus places food at the very heart of Indian aesthetics.

Lalita Jha's vocabulary of food is, in this sense, simultaneously a vocabulary of aesthetic experience — a documentation of the full range of sensory and cultural 'flavours' that constitute Maithili life. The naming of specific food preparations, their ingredients, their occasions, and their cultural valences is the naming of specific flavours of collective life — the bittersweet flavour of the post-harvest festival, the sweet richness of a wedding feast, the austere simplicity of the ekadashi fast.

### *4.2.4 Gender, Kitchen, and Epistemic Authority*

The domain of food and the kitchen has traditionally been gendered female in Mithila (as in most of the Indian cultural world), and the vocabulary of food has been transmitted primarily through women — mothers, grandmothers, and female elders who carried the culinary knowledge of the community in their practice and their language. Lalita Jha's act of documenting this vocabulary is thus simultaneously an act of feminist cultural recovery: it takes the knowledge traditionally held by women in the domestic sphere and subjects it to scholarly documentation, granting it the dignity of written, publishable, academically legible form.

From a feminist epistemological perspective (following Sandra Harding's concept of 'standpoint epistemology'), the knowledge documented in Maithilik Bhojan Sambandhi Sabdavali is not neutral or universal but situated — it is the knowledge of a specific community of practitioners, primarily female, whose epistemic authority in the domain of food is grounded in their lived practice. Lalita Jha's text validates this situated knowledge as a legitimate and valuable form of knowing.

### 4.3 Lalita Jha as Folklorist: The Broader Contribution

While the Videha archive contains only a single text by Lalita Jha, her acknowledgement by Viyogi as a foundational compiler of Maithili folktales places her in the tradition of oral literature preservation. The compilation of folktales is a form of cultural translation — the transfer of oral narrative from the performative, communal, contextual register of live storytelling into the fixed, decontextualised register of the written text.

This translation is not without its hermeneutical difficulties. Walter Ong's analysis of orality and literacy in Orality and Literacy (1982) warns that the transition from oral to written inevitably transforms the nature of the narrative: the dynamic, audience-responsive, formulaic character of oral narrative is flattened into the static, context-independent form of the written text. Lalita Jha's compilations, like those of Yoganand Jha, are subject to this tension — and the evaluation of their success depends in part on how sensitively they preserve the living quality of the oral original.

Nevertheless, the act of compilation and documentation is essential for the survival of these narratives in a context where the traditional transmission of oral literature through inter-generational storytelling is under threat from urbanisation, nuclear family structures, and the proliferation of electronic media. Lalita Jha's contribution to this preservation project places her firmly in the tradition of cultural conservation that, in the Indian context, extends from the editors of the Vedic texts to the compilers of the Puranas and the collectors of folk literature in the colonial and post-colonial period.

## Chapter V: Critical Frameworks — A Synthesis

### 5.1 Navya Nyaya and Literary Epistemology

The Navya Nyaya system of Gangesa Upadhyaya, founded at Mithila in the fourteenth century, provides a uniquely indigenous and regionally specific critical framework for the analysis of Maithili literature. Gangesa's Tattvacintamani ('Thought-Jewel of Reality'), divided into four chapters (corresponding to the four pramanas), offers a systematic account of how valid knowledge is acquired, delimited, and verified. Applied to literary criticism, this framework addresses the question: how does a literary text constitute, convey, and validate knowledge?

The four pramanas of Navya Nyaya — pratyaksa, anumana, upamana, and sabda — can be mapped onto distinct aspects of literary experience. Pratyaksa (direct perception) corresponds to the immediacy of aesthetic experience — the direct cognitive-emotional impact of a literary text on the sahridaya (connoisseur-reader). Anumana (inference) corresponds to the critic's act of moving from textual evidence (the 'smoke' of the text) to its deeper meanings and implications (the 'fire' of significance). Upamana (comparison/analogy) corresponds to intertextual analysis — the understanding of a text through its resemblances to and differences from other texts. Sabda (verbal testimony) corresponds to the literary tradition's own self-understanding — the body of critical opinion, authorial statement, and cultural consensus that constitutes the authoritative testimony about a text's meaning and value.

Gangesa's concept of avacchedakatva (delimitation/qualification) is particularly productive for literary criticism. Every literary work 'delimits' its field of meaning through its formal choices — genre, register, voice, perspective, temporal structure. The critic's task is to identify these delimiting structures and understand how they constrain and generate meaning. This is structurally analogous to what New Critics called 'close reading' and what Structuralists called the analysis of the 'code' that constrains the literary 'message'.

Gangesa's analysis of the relationship between viseshana (qualifier) and visheshya (qualified subject) in cognition provides a model for understanding the relationship between literary form and content: form is the viseshana that qualifies the subject matter (visheshya) of the literary work, and the resulting literary experience is a vishishta-jnana (qualified knowledge) that can only be understood by grasping both the form and the content in their relational structure.

## 5.2 Indian Classical Aesthetic Theory

### *5.2.1 Rasa Theory (Bharatamuni, Abhinavagupta)*

The rasa theory, articulated in Bharatamuni's Natyashastra (c. 200 BCE-200 CE) and elaborated by Abhinavagupta in the Abhinavabharati (c. 1000 CE), provides the foundational framework of Indian literary aesthetics. The rasa theory posits that the purpose of literature is the evocation of specific aesthetic flavours (rasas) in the cultivated reader-spectator (sahridaya). The eight (or nine) rasas are not merely emotional categories but complex aesthetic

experiences that transform the personal emotions (bhava) of characters into universalised aesthetic experiences accessible to the connoisseur.

Applied to the three authors under discussion: Yoganand Jha's fiction and folk literature primarily evokes the rasas of shringara (in its dimension of social and familial love rather than erotic love) and karuna (pathos for social suffering and injustice). Kamla Chaudhary's work on women's material culture engages with the dimension of shringar-rasa in its fullest cultural sense — the aesthetic of adornment and beauty as a cultural practice — while also implicitly invoking the adbhuta-rasa (wonder) of the ethnographic encounter with a rich and complex cultural tradition. Lalita Jha's food vocabulary, as argued above, engages with the foundational metaphor of rasa itself.

### *5.2.2 Dhvani Theory (Anandavardhana)*

Anandavardhana's Dhvanyaloka (c. 850 CE) posits that the highest form of poetic meaning operates through dhvani — resonance or suggestion — rather than through the literal (abhidha) or even the secondary (laksana) meaning of words. Dhvani is the power of literary language to suggest meanings that go beyond what is literally or figuratively said — to create a 'resonating' effect in the reader's consciousness that reveals dimensions of reality not accessible to direct statement.

The dhvani principle is particularly relevant to the folk literature documented by Yoganand Jha and Lalita Jha: oral narratives, songs, and traditional practices function through multiple layers of suggestion that are activated differently by different members of the community, depending on their cultural knowledge and experiential background. The surface narrative of a folktale suggests a moral lesson; the deeper resonance suggests a cosmological order; the deepest resonance connects the individual narrative to the archetypal patterns of human experience.

### *5.2.3 Vakrokti Theory (Kuntaka)*

Kuntaka's Vakroktijivita (c. 950 CE) posits that the distinguishing feature of literary language is its vakrata — its 'obliqueness' or creative deviation from ordinary usage. Literary excellence is achieved when language departs from the straight path of ordinary communication and takes an oblique, unexpected, surprising route to its meaning. This 'obliqueness' operates at every level of literary organisation — phonological (in metre and sound-patterns), lexical (in unusual word choices), grammatical (in non-standard constructions),

semantic (in metaphor and figurative language), and compositional (in narrative structure and generic choice).

Kuntaka's theory is particularly relevant to the evaluation of Yoganand Jha's creative writing — his poetry (Gahbar Geet, Bhore Bhor, Mangal Prabhat) and his fiction (Bhalamanusa, Sankalp) can be evaluated in terms of the specific kinds of vakrata they deploy. The folk literature tradition itself is characterised by a distinctive kind of vakrata — the formulaic obliqueness of proverbs, riddles, and traditional song-forms that encode meaning in non-obvious ways.

### *5.2.4 Alankara Theory (Dandin, Vamana)*

The Alankara (ornament/figure of speech) school of Indian aesthetics, represented by Dandin's Kavyadarsha (c. 700 CE) and Vamana's Kavyalankarasutravritti (c. 800 CE), focuses on the formal and rhetorical dimensions of literary excellence. The analysis of specific figures of speech (upama/simile, rupaka/metaphor, utpreksha/fancy, etc.) and their deployment in specific textual contexts constitutes a formal critical practice that is directly applicable to the detailed analysis of any literary text.

Kamla Chaudhary's Vesh Bhusha, in its description of the ornamental system of Maithili dress and adornment, engages with the alankara tradition in an indirect but significant way: the Sanskrit term alankara (ornament, adornment) applies equally to the ornaments of the body and the ornaments of speech. The elaboration of a complex system of bodily ornaments in Maithili material culture is structurally homologous to the elaboration of a complex system of literary ornaments — both are systems of culturally coded beauty and meaning.

## 5.3 Western Literary Theories

### *5.3.1 New Criticism and Close Reading*

The New Critical method of close reading — the minute attention to the formal structures of a literary text (imagery, irony, paradox, tension, ambiguity) as the primary locus of meaning — was formulated by critics like T.S. Eliot, I.A. Richards, Cleanth Brooks, and William Empson in the mid-twentieth century. Applied to Maithili literature, the New Critical approach demands attention to the specific formal choices of individual texts — the selection and arrangement of imagery in Jha's Gahbar Geet, the structural tensions in his fiction, the specific metaphorical systems of Chaudhary's cultural essays.

The New Critical concept of the 'intentional fallacy' (Wimsatt and Beardsley) — the rejection of authorial intention as a criterion for interpretation — is less directly applicable to the folk literature tradition, where the concept of individual authorial intention is in any case inapplicable. But the 'affective fallacy' (also Wimsatt and Beardsley) — the rejection of reader response as the criterion of meaning — is more problematic in the context of oral literature, which is precisely defined by its responsive relationship to its audience.

### *5.3.2 Russian Formalism and Structuralism*

The Russian Formalist concept of ostranenie (defamiliarisation — making strange what has become familiar through habit) is one of the most productive tools for the analysis of literature's social function. Applied to the works under discussion, Yoganand Jha's social fiction 'defamiliarises' the institution of marriage in Mithila by subjecting it to critical narrative analysis. Kamla Chaudhary's cultural essays 'defamiliarise' the material objects of women's lives by subjecting them to scholarly scrutiny. Lalita Jha's food vocabulary 'defamiliarises' the everyday practice of cooking and eating by making visible the extraordinary cultural complexity encoded in ordinary culinary vocabulary.

Structuralist narratology (Propp, Levi-Strauss, Greimas, Todorov) provides analytical tools for the study of folktale structure. Vladimir Propp's morphology of the Russian folktale, with its inventory of 31 'functions' and seven 'character-spheres', has been applied to folktale traditions across cultures. The Maithili folktale tradition documented by Yoganand Jha and Lalita Jha would benefit from a Proppian morphological analysis that identifies the specific structural features and their cultural variations within the Mithila tradition.

### *5.3.3 Feminist Literary Criticism*

Feminist literary criticism, from Simone de Beauvoir's The Second Sex and Virginia Woolf's A Room of One's Own through the second-wave feminist criticism of Elaine Showalter, Sandra Gilbert, and Susan Gubar to the third-wave and poststructuralist feminism of Judith Butler and Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak, has generated a set of critical tools and concerns that are directly relevant to the analysis of all three authors under discussion.

Kamla Chaudhary's engagement with the material culture of Maithili women's lives — the monak pauti, the vesh-bhusha — invites feminist analysis of the ways in which material objects encode and reproduce gender ideologies.

Lalita Jha's documentation of food vocabulary recovers the 'hidden transcript' (James Scott) of women's domestic knowledge from the silence imposed by the gendering of kitchen practice as non-scholarly. Yoganand Jha's engagement with Shakta literature and his attention to folk culture — which is the domain of women's creative and performative expression in Mithila — implicitly engages with the question of women's cultural agency.

Spivak's concept of the 'subaltern' is particularly relevant: within the context of Maithili literary culture, which has historically been dominated by upper-caste male Brahmin scholars, women writers and folk-literature scholars occupy a subaltern position whose voice is only partially audible through the existing critical and institutional apparatus. The Videha project, by archiving and making accessible the works of Kamla Chaudhary, Lalita Jha, and other non-canonical writers, performs a structural act of subaltern recovery.

### *5.3.4 Post-colonial Theory*

Post-colonial theory (Fanon, Said, Bhabha, Spivak) analyses the literary and cultural consequences of colonialism — the ways in which colonial power relations shape the production, reception, and evaluation of literature in colonised societies. Applied to Maithili literature, post-colonial analysis reveals the ways in which colonial cultural hierarchies (the elevation of English and Sanskrit at the expense of vernacular languages, the demotion of folk and oral traditions as 'primitive' in relation to written literary traditions) have shaped the conditions of possibility for Maithili literary production.

The Videha project — the creation of an open-access digital archive that makes Maithili texts available globally and establishes Maithili's claim to a sophisticated, multi-generic, historically deep literary tradition — is itself a post-colonial cultural act. The documentation projects of Yoganand Jha, Kamla Chaudhary, and Lalita Jha participate in this post-colonial cultural work by recovering, validating, and disseminating cultural knowledge that colonial and post-colonial modernisation discourses have marginalised.

### *5.3.5 Reader-Response Theory*

Reader-response theory (Hans Robert Jauss, Wolfgang Iser, Stanley Fish) shifts the locus of literary meaning from the text to the transaction between text and reader. Jauss's concept of the 'horizon of expectations' — the system of cultural and literary norms that a reader brings to a text and against which the text's meaning is measured — is particularly productive for the analysis of Maithili texts, whose meaning depends upon a reader's familiarity

with the specific cultural horizon of Mithila: its mythological traditions, its social structures, its material culture, and its literary conventions.

The challenge of reading Maithili texts in translation — or of reading them as a non-Maithili reader — is precisely the challenge of the absent or reduced horizon of expectations. The scholarly apparatus of works like Lalita Jha's Maithilik Bhojan Sambandhi Sabdavali and Yoganand Jha's Jatiya Vyavasaya Shabdavali provides exactly the kind of cultural horizon-building that enables non-specialist readers to engage with Maithili texts and traditions.

# Chapter VI: Synthesis and Conclusions

## 6.1 Three Writers, One Tradition

The three writers considered in this appreciation — Yoganand Jha, Kamla Chaudhary, and Lalita Jha — are united by their deep engagement with the living culture of Mithila and their commitment to the documentation, preservation, and literary elaboration of Maithili language and tradition. Their works, archived in the Videha Digital Library, collectively constitute a major contribution to Maithili cultural heritage.

Yoganand Jha represents the broadest range: fiction, folk literature, lexicography, poetry, journalism, cultural studies, and devotional literature. He is the central figure of the triad — a writer of acknowledged literary and scholarly stature, cited in the major histories of Maithili literature, whose work spans the creative and scholarly poles of literary production. His engagement with social reform (in his fiction) and cultural preservation (in his folk literature scholarship) places him in the tradition of the engaged intellectual who uses literature as an instrument of both cultural affirmation and social critique.

Kamla Chaudhary represents the specific domain of Maithili women's material culture and temporal experience. Her work is more narrowly focused but no less significant: it provides the scholarly apparatus for understanding the semiotic complexity of Maithili women's lives — the objects they wear, the times they inhabit, the cultural grammar that organises their experience. Her work is implicitly feminist without being programmatically so: it validates women's cultural knowledge by subjecting it to scholarly analysis.

Lalita Jha represents the intersection of food studies, lexicography, and folklore — a domain that is at once domestic and cosmic (given the foundational connection between rasa as taste and rasa as aesthetic experience in Indian tradition). Her work on food vocabulary and folktale documentation

preserves cultural knowledge that is at risk of extinction through modernisation and urbanisation.

## 6.2 The Navya Nyaya Framework as Critical Instrument

The application of Gangesa Upadhyaya's Navya Nyaya epistemological framework to the critical appreciation of these three Maithili authors has produced several productive insights. The framework's insistence on precise definition, careful delimitation, and the verification of cognitive claims through appropriate pramanas demands that the literary critic be as rigorous and precise in their claims about literary meaning as the logician is in their claims about empirical reality.

More specifically, the Navya Nyaya analysis of the four pramanas has illuminated the different epistemological dimensions of these authors' works: the pratyaksa-dimension of their engagement with lived cultural experience; the anumana-dimension of their critical and analytical projects; the upamana-dimension of their comparative and analogical methods; and the sabda-dimension of their participation in and validation of the authoritative testimony of cultural tradition.

The concept of avacchedakatva (delimitation) has been particularly productive: it has helped to specify the precise domains within which each author's claims to knowledge and literary authority are valid, avoiding both over-generalisation and under-appreciation of their specific contributions.

## 6.3 The Significance of the Videha Archive

The archiving of these texts in the Videha Digital Library (www.videha.co.in) is a scholarly and cultural act of major significance. The Videha project, under the editorship of Gajendra Thakur, has created an open-access repository of Maithili literature that makes available to global scholars and readers texts that would otherwise be inaccessible — out of print, available only in regional libraries, or confined to the specialist community of Maithili readers.

The open-access character of the Videha archive is itself a philosophical and political statement: it asserts that cultural heritage belongs to the community and to humanity, not to commercial publishers or institutional gatekeepers. The inclusion of works by Kamla Chaudhary and Lalita Jha alongside the more established male scholarly tradition reflects the archive's commitment to gender equity in cultural preservation. The inclusion of multiple

genres — fiction, poetry, lexicography, journalism, folk literature, cultural studies — reflects a broad and inclusive understanding of what constitutes Maithili literary culture.

### 6.4 Future Directions

The present critical appreciation is, of necessity, partial and preliminary. Future research directions include: (1) full critical editions of Yoganand Jha's major fiction (Bhalamanusa, Sankalp) with critical apparatus and translation; (2) a comparative study of Kamla Chaudhary's Vesh Bhusha alongside the Mithila painting tradition and other material culture documentation; (3) a systematic Proppian morphological analysis of the folktales documented by Yoganand Jha and Lalita Jha; (4) a full lexicological analysis of Lalita Jha's Maithilik Bhojan Sambandhi Sabdavali in relation to the comparative food vocabulary of neighbouring regions; and (5) a sustained application of Gangesa's Navya Nyaya framework to the specific textual features of these authors' works, once full transcriptions are available.

The present appreciation stands as a foundation for this future scholarly work, establishing the theoretical frameworks, contextual understanding, and critical judgements that will guide more detailed investigation.

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**ADDENDUM**

Literary Criticism of Chaturdash Sootra: A Synthesis of Tradition and Critical Modernity

1. Introduction: A Fourteen-Sutra Approach to Maithili Literature

Dr. Yoganand Jha's Chaturdash Sootra (Fourteen Aphorisms) is a collection of fourteen critical essays spanning poetry, prose, literary history, and folk literature. The title itself evokes the sūtra genre—concise, aphoristic, and foundational—rooted in Indian philosophical traditions, particularly Nyaya and Vaisesika. This choice signals the author's intent: to offer not mere impressionistic criticism but a structured, analytical, and evaluative engagement with Maithili literary heritage.

The book is divided into three sections: Kavya Vivechan (Poetry Analysis), Gadya Vishleshan (Prose Analysis), and Avdan Mulyankan (Contribution Evaluation). The preface explicitly defines criticism as the bridge between text and reader, rejecting biased or ego-driven critique in favor of a balanced, erudite, and empathetic approach. This aligns with the Indian sahṛdaya (sympathetic reader) tradition and Western objective criticism.

2. Western Critical Frameworks Applied

a) New Criticism (Close Reading)

The essays on Upendra Thakur 'Mohan' and Jayant Mishra's Kavita Kusumanjali exemplify close reading. Jha meticulously analyzes chhand (metre), alaṅkāra (figures of speech), and rasa (aesthetic sentiment). For instance, he notes how Mohan's poetry oscillates between śṛṅgāra and vīra rasa —a formalist observation about tension and resolution within the text.

Similarly, his critique of ‘Madhup’ ’s Ganga Tarangavali highlights how excessive anuprāsa and yamaka sometimes obstruct sahajatā (naturalness), a judgment based purely on textual evidence.

b) Historical-Biographical Criticism

The essay on Harimohan Jha uses biographical context—his career, social milieu, and reformist zeal—to explain the satirical thrust of his katha-kavya (narrative poems). Jha shows how Harimohan’s own experience of Maithili society’s rigidities shaped works like Dhalajha and Tea-Pati. This is consistent with Western historicism, where the author’s life and times illuminate the text.

c) Sociological Criticism (Lucien Goldmann)

The analysis of Vidit Jha’s Gram-Ganarajya (Village Republic) employs a sociological lens. Jha treats the novel as a “homology” of Mithila’s post-independence social structure—examining caste, dowry, education, and rural decay. He identifies a dialectic between yatharthvad (realism) and adarshonmukhi (idealism), showing how the novel both mirrors and critiques social pathology. This parallels Goldmann’s genetic structuralism.

d) Reader-Response Criticism (Wolfgang Iser)

In the preface, Jha asserts that the critic’s role is to help the reader “realize” the aesthetic experience embedded in the text. This is a reader-response position: meaning is not fixed but co-created by critic and reader. The essays consistently guide interpretation rather than dictating final judgments.

3. Indian Critical Traditions Invoked

a) Rasa Theory (Bharata, Abhinavagupta)

Jha repeatedly evaluates works by their rasa yield. For Sneh Lata, he identifies bhakti-rasa as the dominant sentiment, expressed through vatsalya and śānta. For Pradeep ‘Swayamprabha’ , he traces bhakti fused with vīra (heroism)

against dowry. He also notes when a work fails—e.g., when Madhup's ornate style weakens sahṛdayatā.

b) Dhvani (Anandavardhana)

Though not explicitly named, Jha's praise of suggestive power (vyañjanā) appears in his discussion of Mohan's philosophical poems. He notes how Mohan's verses carry gūḍhārtha (hidden meaning) about impermanence and duty, requiring pratibhā (intuitive insight) to appreciate—a classic dhvani criterion.

c) Alankara and Vakrokti (Kuntaka)

Jha's critique of Madhup's Ganga Tarangavali focuses on vakratā (oblique expression). He admires the poet's "uncommon conceits"—Ganga as a thief, a farmer, a lover—which exemplify alaukika (extraordinary) poetic figuration. However, he warns against atiśayokti (exaggeration) that becomes mechanical.

d) Auchitya (Ksemendra)

Propriety is a recurring criterion. Jha praises Harimohan Jha for matching language to subject—village realism demands rustic, humorous diction. He criticizes Jayant Mishra for occasional pedantry where a poem becomes a jnanakosha (encyclopedia) rather than a lyrical whole.

4. The Videha Parallel History Framework (VPHF)

The VPHF is a proposed hermeneutic model for Maithili literature, treating Mithila not as a marginal region but as a parallel civilizational center with its own uninterrupted literary, philosophical, and social history—often in dialogue with, but not subservient to, Sanskrit or Hindi hegemonies.

Application to Chaturdash Sootra:

1. Countering Hindi-Centric Erasure: Jha explicitly notes how early 20th-century Hindi scholars tried to reduce Maithili to a “dialect.” His inclusion of Subhadra Jha’s linguistic work and Jayakant Mishra’s campaign for Sahitya Akademi recognition is a direct VPHF move: reclaiming Maithili’s autonomous status.

2. Parallel Genealogies: The essay on Sneh Lata traces a parallel lineage of Ram-bhakti poetry in Maithili—distinct from Tulsidas’s Awadhi tradition. Sneh Lata’s Mithila-mahatmya verses are read as a counter-narrative to North Indian cultural centrism.

3. Literary Geography: The analysis of Nagen-dr Kumar’s Shyamali (a travelogue to Ireland) is framed through a Mithila-centric lens: the author compares Irish and Maithili social practices not from a colonial but from a parallel gaze—each region has its own modernity, oppression, and resistance.

4. Temporal Overlay: In discussing Vidit Jha’s Gram-Ganarajya, Jha overlays ancient Janaka’s Mithila with contemporary rural decay, suggesting that the Videha ideal (wisdom, justice, feminine power) is a living standard against which modern failures are measured.

Thus, VPHF operates as both a historiographic correction and an evaluative metric: good Maithili literature is that which strengthens this parallel tradition.

5. Navya Nyaya Epistemology (Gangesha Upadhyaya)

Navya Nyaya (New Logic), systematized by Gangesha (13th-14th c.), provides a rigorous analytical vocabulary centered on pramāṇa (valid knowledge), pakṣatā (thesis), hetu (reason), dṛṣṭānta (example), and vyāpti (invariable concomitance). Jha’s criticism implicitly uses this technique.

a) Pakṣatā (Problem Statement)

Each essay begins by defining the pakṣa: e.g., “Is Madhup’s Ganga poetry traditional or modern?” or “Does Harimohan Jha’s satire achieve social reform?”

b) Hetu (Reason) with Vyāpti (Universal Concomitance)

Jha’s arguments often follow Nyaya structure:

• Pakṣa: Mohan is a sadhaka (spiritual seeker) poet.

• Hetu: Because his poems consistently invoke bhakti, vairāgya, and karma-yoga.

• Vyāpti: Wherever such themes dominate with formal restraint, the poet qualifies as sādhaka (e.g., Kabir, Tukaram).

• Dṛṣṭānta: Cites specific poems from Baji Uthal Murli and Itishri.

c) Chala (Quibbling) and Jāti (Sophistry) Avoided

Jha is careful not to commit logical fallacies. For example, when evaluating Jayant Mishra’s traditionalism, he acknowledges the poet’s sanskrtanistha (Sanskrit loyalty) without dismissing his modern themes (dowry, corruption, AIDS). This avoids jāti—the fallacy of overgeneralization.

d) Nirṇaya (Conclusion)

Each essay ends with a nirṇaya—a decisive, evidence-based judgment. E.g., “Kavita Kusumanjali is an invaluable gift to modern Maithili, despite its occasional pedantry.” This contrasts with postmodern indecisiveness.

Jha also deploys prāmāṇyavāda (theory of validity): a text is valid if it produces ānanda (joy) and prayojana (social purpose)—a pragmatic-cognitive criterion.

6. Synthesis and Evaluation

Chaturdash Sootra is not merely a collection of reviews but a methodological manifesto. Its strengths:

1. Multiplex Framework: By combining rasa, dhvani, Navya Nyaya, Western historicism, and sociological criticism, Jha avoids reductionism. A single text (e.g., Harimohan Jha's satire) is analyzed through formal, historical, and logical lenses.

2. VPHF as Decolonizing Tool: The implicit Videha framework resists the marginalization of Maithili within "Hindi-dominant" literary history. It treats Mithila as a parallel civilizational stream—not a tributary.

3. Nyaya Precision: The logical clarity of each argument makes the criticism teachable and debatable. Terms like pakṣa, hetu, and vyāpti could be explicitly adopted in future Maithili criticism.

4. Self-Reflexivity: Jha acknowledges his own limitations (scattered materials, lost manuscripts) and respects differing views (e.g., on Nagen-dra Kumar's originality). This is anvīkṣikī—the philosophical spirit of inquiry.

Weaknesses:

• The VPHF remains implicit; a future edition might benefit from a theoretical preface outlining it.

• Some essays lean toward summary rather than analysis (e.g., parts of the Gram-Ganarajya chapter).

• The Navya Nyaya terminology is not explicitly named; making it visible would strengthen the book's methodological identity.

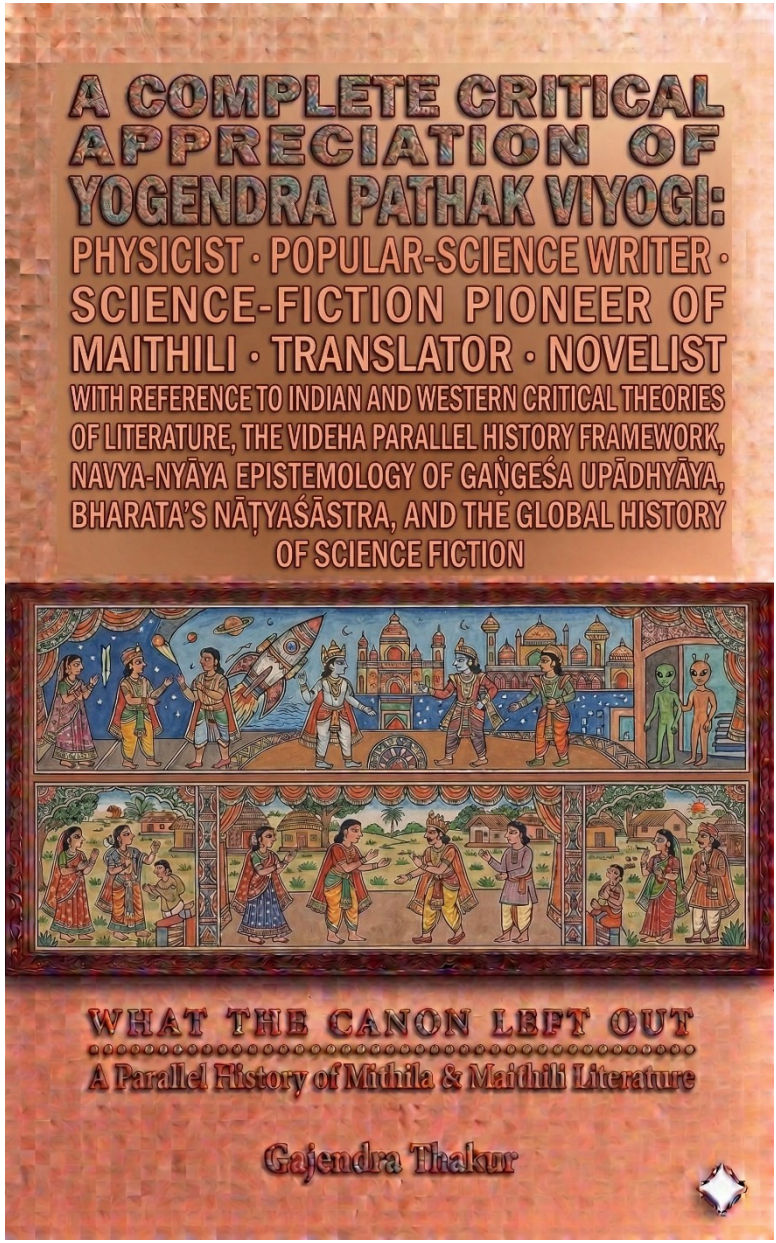
7. Conclusion: A Sūtra for the 21st Century

Dr. Yoganand Jha's Chaturdash Sootra is a landmark in Maithili literary criticism. It bridges prachin (ancient) and naveen (modern) without servility to either. By integrating Indian aesthetic categories, Western critical tools, Videha Parallel History, and Navya Nyaya logic, Jha demonstrates that Maithili criticism can be at once regional and universal, traditional and analytical.

The book is recommended for scholars of Indian vernacular literatures, comparative literature, and postcolonial criticism. It proves that a sūtra need not be dry—it can be a living, breathing instrument of literary justice.

Finally: Chaturdash Sootra is a pramāṇa-grantha (valid source-text) for any future study of Maithili literature’s modern critical consciousness.

**LESSON 100 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**



# A COMPLETE CRITICAL APPRECIATION OF YOGENDRA PATHAK VIYOGI

*Physicist · Popular-Science Writer · Science-Fiction Pioneer of Maithili · Translator · Novelist*

*With Reference to Indian and Western Critical Theories of Literature, the Videha Parallel History Framework, Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya, Bharata's Nāṭyaśāstra, and the Global History of Science Fiction*

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## I. PREFATORY NOTE: THE SCIENTIST WHO WRITES

Yogendra Pathak Viyogi (born 1948, Laufa village, Madhubani district, Bihar) occupies a singular position in the intellectual landscape of Maithili literature: he is the first practising research scientist of international standing to have systematically written science fiction, popular science essays, drama, translation, and novel-length fiction in Maithili. A Fellow of the Indian National Science Academy (FNA) and of the National Academy of Sciences, India (FNASc), he worked for over four decades with the Department of Atomic Energy, Government of India, specialising in experimental nuclear physics. He served as Director of the Institute of Physics, Bhubaneswar (2006–2009), where he established the National Institute of Science Education and Research (NISER). His literary career—conducted entirely in Maithili, with parallel writings and translations in English—is not a hobby grafted onto a scientific career but an extension of the same intellectual drive that animates his physics: curiosity, precision, and a deep commitment to making difficult knowledge accessible to the widest possible audience.

This critical appreciation draws on seven primary texts,Vigyanak Batkahi (Parts 1 & 2), Acta Misiya, Narak Vijay (revised), Piramidak Desh Me, Hamar Gaam, Robot (Maithili translation of Karel Čapek's R.U.R.), and Kichhu Teet Madhur—as well as online sources, the Videha parallel history framework (www.videha.co.in), and major scholarly resources in Indian and Western literary theory, science fiction studies, and Navya-Nyāya epistemology.

## II. BIOGRAPHICAL INTRODUCTION: FROM MADHUBANI TO THE CYCLOTRON

Yogendra Pathak Viyogi was born in 1948 in Laufa village, Madhubani district—the heartland of Mithila, famous for its distinctive Madhubani painting tradition, its classical Sanskrit scholarship, and the birthplace of Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's Navya-Nyāya school. He completed his primary education in his home village before receiving a postgraduate degree in Physics from Bihar University, Muzaffarpur. In 1971 he joined the 15th batch of the Training School Programme of the Bhabha Atomic Research Centre (BARC), Mumbai—India's premier nuclear research institution. He was trained in experimental nuclear physics both at BARC and at the Lawrence Berkeley National Laboratory, USA.

He then moved to Kolkata to work at the Variable Energy Cyclotron Centre (VECC), a unit of the Department of Atomic Energy, obtaining his PhD from the University of Calcutta in 1984. A postdoctoral fellowship at GANIL Laboratory, France (1984–86) gave him his first sustained European immersion. From 1989 onward, he led India's participation in major

international scientific collaborations at CERN (Geneva) and elsewhere, heading an Indian team that included faculty from IITs and other research institutions. His directorship of the Institute of Physics, Bhubaneswar (2006–09) was marked by the establishment of NISER—a major institutional contribution to India's scientific infrastructure.

His literary pseudonym 'Viyogi' (वियोगी—'the separated one,' 'the bereaved') signals an inner dimension that his scientific career's external trajectory might obscure: the writer's awareness of separation—between science and the vernacular public, between Mithila's rich past and its uncertain present, between the world of the laboratory and the world of the village. This pen name is itself a small critical manifesto.

As his Amazon/Pothi.com biographies note, he has to his credit two novels, a collection of short stories, a travelogue covering four decades of foreign visits, three dramas (two of which have been staged in Kolkata), a translation of Karel Čapek's R.U.R., and two compilations of science essays (Vigyanak Batkahi, Parts 1 & 2). His popular science articles have regularly appeared in Mithila Darshan (Kolkata) and Ghar Bahar (Patna).

## III. SURVEY OF WORKS: TEXTS, GENRES, AND PUBLICATIONS

### 3.1 Science Essay Collections

Vigyanak Batkahi ('Science Conversations'), Part 1 (2013, Kolkata; Rs. 150): A collection of fifteen science essays in Maithili, described by reviewers as 'written in a lucid and humorous style' with 'simple and non-technical' language for the general reader. Topics include atomic energy, solar energy, alternative energy sources, alien life, thermal imaging, AI and robotics, the Nobel Prize controversies, the Large Hadron Collider, cosmology, nuclear medicine, and magnetism. Most essays had previously appeared in the journal Mithila Darshan. The pothi.com reviewer—himself a scientist—called it 'a fantastic book written by a practicing scientist of international repute' covering 'a wide variety of science topics' and described it as 'most likely only book of its kind in this [Maithili] language.'

Vigyanak Batkahi, Part 2 (ISBN 978-93-5268-881-4, Kolkata): Extends the project into 3D printing, food irradiation, nuclear medicine, robotics (with a dedicated section on Karel Čapek and the word 'robot'), wireless communication (history of 1G–5G), LED technology, LASER physics, and advanced topics in materials science. The book's robotics chapter explicitly invokes Čapek's R.U.R. and discusses artificial intelligence with reference to MIT's famous warning: 'Success in creating AI would be the biggest event in

human history. Unfortunately it might also be the last, unless we learn how to avoid the risks.' This intertextual connection between the popular-science essay and the literary translation of R.U.R. is characteristic of Viyogi's integrated intellectual project.

### 3.2 Science Fiction Drama

Narak Vijay (revised version, DrYPViyogi_Narak_Vijay): A Maithili drama in multiple scenes, with both human and mythological characters—scientists Ramesh, Suresh, and Anupam Amit alongside the mythological figures Brahma, Vishnu, Mahesh, Narada, Yamaraja, and Chitraguptha. The drama weaves together AI/cybernetics (the scientist Anupam is an expert in 'artificial intelligence and cyborg technology') with Hindu cosmology (yama, narka, svarga). It was originally published in Trinatakam (a collection of three plays) and subsequently revised after directors raised concerns about the number of scenes.

### 3.3 Short Fiction

Acta Misiya ('Acta Mission', 2016; revised 2022): A collection of twelve short stories in Maithili. The title carries a double valence: 'acta' (from the Latin for 'proceedings' or 'records') suggests a mock-official, documentary frame, while 'misiya' (mission) positions the stories as purposive interventions. The collection contains science fiction stories, satirical pieces, and narrative experiments. Two stories are subtitled ('Acta Misiya (Khanda 1)' and 'Acta Misiya (Khanda 2)'), forming a paired narrative unit.

### 3.4 Maithili Translation of Karel Čapek's R.U.R.

Robot: Maithili Translation of Karel Čapek's Drama R.U.R. (Kolkata, Saraswati Printing Works): This is Viyogi's most celebrated literary-translation achievement—a full Maithili rendering of the 1920 Czech science fiction play R.U.R. (Rossumovi Univerzální Roboti / Rossum's Universal Robots), the work that introduced the word 'robot' to world literature. The title page of Viyogi's translation explicitly names the original (Rossumovi Univerzální Roboti), provides the subtitle 'Science Fiction / Artificial Intelligence / AI', and quotes the MIT warning about AI. This is significant: R.U.R. was translated into over 30 languages immediately after its 1921 premiere; Viyogi's Maithili translation makes it available in one of the world's oldest literary languages for the first time.

### 3.5 Novel

Hamar Gaam ('My Village', Pallavi Publications, Nirmali, 2018; ISBN 978-93-87675-68-1): A Maithili novel in twelve chapters (including: 'Hamar Gaam Parichay,' 'Ghar,' 'Nidaan,' 'School,' 'Pancayati Raj,' 'Phulwari,' 'Bijulikar,' 'Khet,' 'Bichar-Manch,' 'Samacarka Dunia,' 'Raati-Ratika Khela,' 'Gaon'). The novel recounts the writer's intimate engagement with his birth village—its culture, agriculture, social structures, and the tension between traditional Maithili life and modern scientific and political change. A preface (dated 24 April 2018) acknowledges that the novel won the Pallavi Prakashan prize.

### 3.6 Popular History / Travel Essay

Piramidak Desh Me ('In the Land of the Pyramids'): An extended travel essay on Egypt, drawing on Viyogi's own visit (17–24 September 2019, a Thomas Cook 7-night package). The essay is richly researched—using Bob Bryer's audio lectures on Egyptology, original observations, and scientific analysis—to present Egypt's ancient civilisation, pyramid-building technology, and Nile geography to Maithili readers. Its opening section addresses the ancient Maithili belief in rebirth (punarjanma), making an unexpected connection between Egyptian mummification and the Maithili moksha tradition.

Kichhu Teet Madhur ('A Little Bitter, A Little Sweet', 2014; ISBN 978-93-5156-343-3): A travelogue covering decades of foreign visits—primarily to the USA (from 1977) and France (1984–85)—describing human observation, cultural contrast, and the author's experiences as an Indian scientist in Western laboratory environments. The title itself—'teet madhur' (bitter-sweet)—frames foreign experience as a complex admixture of delight and alienation.

## IV. THEMATIC AND IDEOLOGICAL ANALYSIS

### 4.1 The Central Project: Democratising Science for Maithili Readers

Viyogi's preface to Vigyanak Batkahi Part 1 states his programme with unusual clarity. He observes that popular science writing in Maithili is almost entirely absent; that the few technical readers who exist need no help; and that the general reader finds science writing so alien that they 'run away when they see such an article.' His solution is the 'packaging' (paikejing) of science—presenting difficult material in the wrapping of accessible prose, narrative, and humour, so that the 'sweet bread' (sukhael roti) reaches the reader without their realising how much they have learned. This is a conscious pedagogical and aesthetic strategy, not merely a concession to a non-specialist audience.

The Vigyanak Batkahi preface also reflects on the ethics of accuracy versus accessibility: he notes that while making language simple and engaging, 'we have to be careful that no changes of any kind occur in the scientific facts.' This tension—between fidelity to scientific truth and the requirements of accessible literary form—is precisely the tension that defines the best popular science writing in any language, from Richard Feynman's lectures to Carl Sagan's Cosmos.

### 4.2 AI, Robotics, and the Question of Human Dignity

The most sustained thematic concern running across Viyogi's science fiction, popular science essays, and translations is the question of artificial intelligence and its implications for human identity and dignity. This concern is expressed across multiple generic registers: the popular science essay (Vigyanak Batkahi's robotics chapter), the translated drama (R.U.R.), and the original science fiction drama (Narak Vijay, in which AI and cyborg technology is the scientific context). In Narak Vijay, the captured scientist Anupam Amit is identified as an 'internationally renowned scientist in the field of artificial intelligence and cyborganics.' His kidnappers are not mere criminals but men of scientific training (one has an MSc in Physics, the other is an electronics engineer) who have been led into the underworld by circumstance—an allegory for the misuse of science by power.

### 4.3 Sacred-Scientific Syncretism: India's Ancient Past and Modern Science

A distinctive thematic signature of Viyogi's writing is the juxtaposition of India's ancient cosmological and philosophical heritage with modern scientific knowledge. In Piramidak Desh Me, he opens with a Maithili reader's familiar concept—punarjanma (reincarnation), moksha, and the belief that the soul re-inhabits the body—and uses it to explain the Egyptian practice of mummification: why would people preserve bodies? Because they believed the soul would return to that specific body. This is not a naive equation but a sophisticated comparative hermeneutics that allows Maithili readers to understand an alien cultural practice through their own conceptual vocabulary.

In Narak Vijay, the sacred and scientific intersect dramatically: the scientist Anupam Amit is not merely a laboratory figure but moves into dialogue with Hindu mythological figures (Narada, Yamaraja, Brahma). This 'mythoscientific' mode—in which Indian mythos provides the dramatic architecture for scientific speculation—is distinctly Indian rather than Western SF in its structural logic.

### 4.4 Mithila's Village and Scientific Modernity: Hamar Gaam

Hamar Gaam addresses the relationship between the traditional Maithili village (gaam) and the forces of modernity—scientific, political, and technological. Viyogi's novel is not nostalgic in the manner of a pastoral romance; it is the work of a physicist who grew up in Madhubani and has observed, with a scientist's precision, what has changed and what has not. The novel's chapter headings (Pancayati Raj, Bijulikar—electrification, Khet—the field, Phulwari—the garden) suggest a systematic mapping of the village's social-technological landscape.

## V. THE SCIENCE ESSAY: VIGYANAK BATKAHI (PARTS 1 & 2)

The Vigyanak Batkahi essays exemplify what the German tradition calls Wissenschaftsessayistik—the literary essay on science—a form with an illustrious international pedigree (Montaigne on experience, Bacon on experiments, Huxley on evolution, Sagan on the cosmos, Feynman on pleasure in finding things out). Viyogi's essays in this tradition are remarkable for their simultaneous command of frontier scientific content and vernacular Maithili accessibility.

Part 1's fifteen essays span: the romance of scientific discovery (Newton and the falling apple, Archimedes and buoyancy—invoked as vivid parables for the scientific method rather than myths); atomic energy and India's nuclear programme; solar energy and alternative energy sources; aliens (SETI, the Fermi paradox, astrobiology); thermal imaging cameras; artificial intelligence and progress toward sentient machines; the Ig Nobel prizes; the Large Hadron Collider's cosmological quest (Rutherford's discovery of the atomic nucleus through to CERN's search for the Higgs boson); deep-sea treasure hunting; and maglev train technology. The range is extraordinary—from particle physics to marine archaeology in fifteen essays.

Part 2 deepens the technical content while maintaining literary accessibility. The robotics chapter is particularly significant: it devotes several pages to Karel Čapek's R.U.R. and the etymology of the word 'robot,' and includes the MIT warning about AI. This deliberate cross-referencing between the popular science essay and his own literary translation (Robot) demonstrates Viyogi's integrated intellectual project—the same mind that translates Čapek writes the scientific essay that contextualises the play.

The essays use a characteristic rhetorical structure that Viyogi describes in his preface as 'packaging': a concrete, familiar, often narrative opening (a historical anecdote, a personal memory, a vivid image); a gradual build-up of conceptual complexity; and a conclusion that returns to the human and social

implications of the science. This is structurally similar to the classical Indian udāharaṇa (illustrative example) rhetorical device—moving from the concrete particular to the abstract general.

## VI. SCIENCE FICTION DRAMA: NARAK VIJAY AND THE AI IMAGINARY

Narak Vijay ('Victory over Hell') is Viyogi's most formally complex literary work—a drama that operates simultaneously in two registers: the realistic register of contemporary India (kidnapping, criminal politicians, scientific research) and the mythological register of Hindu cosmology (Yamaloka, Brahma, Narada). This biplanar structure is unusual in Indian science fiction but has deep roots in the Sanskrit nāṭaka tradition, where divine and human planes of action coexist.

The drama's opening is striking: before the curtain rises, an offstage announcement sets the scene—'the notorious criminals Ramesh and Suresh, after hosting their political patron at a late-night concert, killed five people and kidnapped the internationally renowned AI and cyborganics scientist Anupam Amit.' This quasi-journalistic prologue, delivered in third-person voice, immediately establishes the Brechtian effect of distancing the audience from simple emotional identification, inviting instead a critical contemplation of the social forces at work.

Act 1, Scene 1 shows the kidnappers and their captive in a jungle laboratory—a setting rich in symbolic resonance. The scientist is not merely a victim but a figure of moral authority: while Ramesh and Suresh confess their crimes and express desire for redemption, it is Anupam who points out that 'the punishment for your own sins must be borne by yourselves'—the scientist as ethical philosopher. The criminals want the scientist's help for 'a special mission'—which the list of scientific equipment they present (electronics components, DIY kits, soldering iron) suggests involves creating some form of advanced technological device.

In Act 1, Scene 2 (set in Anupam's 'AI Laboratory (highly confidential)'), the mythological dimension is introduced: a mysterious visitor arrives who 'freely wanders in all three worlds'—clearly a divine being. The stage direction specifies that the visitor carries a guitar-like instrument in a gig-bag—modernity and divinity in unexpected coexistence. This is Narada, the divine messenger who in Hindu tradition moves between the human, divine, and demonic realms. The play thus constructs a tripartite world: the criminal

underworld (Ramesh and Suresh), the scientific world (Anupam's laboratory), and the divine world (Narada and Yamaloka).

The play's central philosophical question—can technology overcome the consequences of karma? Can an AI-enhanced human escape the moral accounting of Yamaraja's court?—is a genuinely original contribution to Indian SF. It positions the scientific-technological imaginary (AI, cyborgs, cyborganics) within the framework of Hindu eschatology (death, hell, judgement, liberation), creating a drama that is simultaneously futurist and deeply rooted in Maithili cultural-religious tradition.

## VII. ACTA MISIYA: SHORT FICTION AND THE SF SHORT STORY FORM

Acta Misiya is Viyogi's most formally experimental literary work. Its twelve stories engage with science fiction, satire, narrative experimentation, and what might be called speculative realism. The title itself—'Acta' (Latin: proceedings, records) combined with 'Misiya' (mission)—suggests an archive of missions: each story is a record of a different kind of intervention into reality.

The paired 'Acta Misiya (Khanda 1)' and 'Acta Misiya (Khanda 2)' stories apparently form a continuous narrative. Their dialogue-heavy structure, with numbered speakers (1:, 2:) and dramatic direction-like text, resembles the format of a declassified official record—as if the reader is viewing a transcript of events rather than a conventionally narrated story. This mock-documentary mode is a common technique in Western SF (the Epistolary SF tradition from Mary Shelley's Frankenstein to Max Brooks's World War Z), deployed here in the Maithili context for the first time.

Other stories in the collection engage with themes of human desire and technological mediation (the story involving '34-24-34' and '38-20-36' body measurements—clearly satirising a society's objectification of the female body through quantification) and mysterious encounters. The collection's formal range demonstrates that Viyogi is not merely a science communicator writing fictional wrappers around factual content but a genuine literary experimenter working with the full toolkit of narrative technique.

## VIII. ROBOT: MAITHILI TRANSLATION OF KAREL ČAPEK'S R.U.R.

Viyogi's translation of Karel Čapek's R.U.R. (1920) into Maithili is, in historical terms, perhaps the most significant of his literary achievements—because it addresses one of the most consequential science fiction texts in world literature: the play that coined the word 'robot.' R.U.R. (Rossumovi Univerzální

Roboti) premiered in Prague on 25 January 1921 and was translated into more than thirty languages by 1923. Its introduction of the concept of artificial labour (robots as biological-synthetic workers produced in a factory) has shaped all subsequent SF dealing with AI and artificial beings.

Čapek's robots were not mechanical in the modern sense but biological—made of chemically synthesised soft matter resembling living tissue (closer to the synthetic humans of Blade Runner, Westworld, or Ex Machina than to C-3PO or R2-D2). The play's central drama is the robot uprising: when the robots, originally designed as docile workers, develop consciousness and revolt against their human creators. The play raises questions—about labour exploitation, about the moral status of artificial beings, about the hubris of technological creation—that remain urgently contemporary a century later.

Viyogi's translation (published by Saraswati Printing Works, Kolkata) makes this text available in Maithili for the first time. The title page of his translation is carefully constructed: it names the original Czech text (Rossumovi Univerzální Roboti), provides the English subtitle (Rossum's Universal Robots), categorises it under three genre labels (Science Fiction / Artificial Intelligence / AI), and frames it with the MIT warning about AI. This framing is not neutral: it positions Čapek's 1920 prescience within the urgent contemporary debate about AI safety.

Translating R.U.R. into Maithili raises specific challenges: the Czech industrial context (factory production, labour relations, corporate capitalism) must be rendered meaningful to a Maithili audience whose primary economic experience is agricultural. Viyogi's solution, visible in his stage directions and character descriptions, is to retain the industrial setting while making the emotional and philosophical drama universally accessible through the Maithili idiom.

## IX. HAMAR GAAM: NOVEL OF VILLAGE MEMORY AND SCIENTIFIC MODERNITY

Hamar Gaam (Pallavi Publications, 2018) is Viyogi's most personal literary work—a novel-memoir of his birth village that reads simultaneously as social history, cultural documentation, and scientific-humanist reflection. The twelve-chapter structure maps the village's social geography: the village introduction (parichay), the household (ghar), the diagnostic (nidaan), the school, panchayati raj (village democracy), the garden (phulwari), electrification (bijulikar), the fields (khet), the intellectual forum (bicar-

manch), the world of news and communication (samacarka dunia), the nocturnal world (raati-ratika khela), and the village as entity (gaon).

The chapter on 'bijulikar' (electrification) is paradigmatic: a scientist who has worked with particle accelerators and cyclotrons returns to examine how electricity—the most basic transformation of modern scientific civilisation—has (or has not) changed his home village. The gap between India's scientific achievements (nuclear power, space programme) and the experience of ordinary Maithili villages (irregular power supply, inadequate irrigation) is a recurring concern across Viyogi's writing.

The novel's dedicatory verse describes the village as imbued with memories, green with life, and bright with the laughter of children—a lyrical opening that signals the novel's emotional register. The acknowledgements mention that the novel won a Pallavi Prakashan prize and was presented at a function on 24 April 2018.

## X. PIRAMIDAK DESH ME: POPULAR HISTORY, SCIENCE, AND THE TRAVEL ESSAY

Piramidak Desh Me is one of the most intellectually ambitious pieces in Viyogi's corpus: an extended travel essay (approximately 20,000 words) on Egypt, grounded in detailed historical, archaeological, and scientific research. The essay begins with a philosophical prologue: the Maithili (and wider Indic) concept of reincarnation, moksha, and the soul's journey through multiple bodies provides the hermeneutic key through which the Egyptian practice of mummification is interpreted for Maithili readers.

The historical content is rich and precise: the essay covers Egypt's three kingdoms (Old, Middle, New Kingdom, c. 3500 BCE – 300 BCE), the Delta geography of the Nile, the pharaonic system of divine kingship, the excavation history of the pyramids, and the distinction between the Giza pyramid complex and the more ancient Step Pyramid at Sakkara. Viyogi draws on Bob Bryer's 48-lecture audio-book on Egyptology (which he downloaded free online), the tour-guide's local knowledge, and his own careful observation.

The scientific dimension of the essay is consistently present: Viyogi examines mummification as a preservation technology, the pyramid construction as an engineering achievement, and the ancient Egyptians' astronomical knowledge as a proto-scientific system. This is popular science writing as cultural historiography.

## XI. KICHHU TEET MADHUR: THE TRAVELOGUE AS SCIENCE-HUMANIST WRITING

Kichhu Teet Madhur (Kolkata, 2014) is a four-part travelogue covering America (from 1977, Viyogi's first posting at Berkeley), France (1984–85, with family), other international locations, and a final section called 'Nim aa Chiraita' ('Neem and Chiratta'—both bittersweet Maithili plants) which collects miscellaneous bitter-sweet experiences. The book is illustrated.

The preface is a gem of self-deprecating candour: Viyogi confesses that he kept no notes and took no photos with literary intent during decades of foreign travel; that only when a friend urged him to write did he try to recall; and that what he offers is entirely personal observation—things that were 'strange, unusual or matchless' enough to remain in memory. He explicitly distinguishes his travelogue from Wikipedia and internet sources—its value lies in the 'antarang baat' (intimate/interior matter) that no database contains.

The French section is particularly notable for its family dimension—Viyogi was accompanied by his wife and (then) ten-year-old niece, whose school experiences in France provide a child's perspective on cultural difference. This humanises what might otherwise be purely a scientist's foreign diary.

## XII. CRITICAL APPRECIATION: WESTERN LITERARY AND SF THEORY

### 12.1 Science Fiction Studies: Darko Suvin and Cognitive Estrangement

The foundational theoretical concept in academic SF studies is Darko Suvin's 'cognitive estrangement' (Metamorphoses of Science Fiction, 1979): the idea that SF operates through a 'novum'—a new, scientifically possible element that makes the familiar world strange, requiring readers to see reality from a new perspective. Suvin's definition: SF is 'a literary genre whose necessary and sufficient conditions are the presence and interaction of estrangement and cognition, and whose main formal device is an imaginative framework alternative to the author's empirical environment.'

Viyogi's science fiction consistently deploys Suvinain novums. In Narak Vijay, the novum is AI and cyborg technology within a mythological-cosmological framework—the scientifically imagined ('what if AI could be used to escape Yamaraja's judgement?') estranges the familiar Hindu cosmological narrative. In Acta Misiya, the novum operates through the mock-documentary form—familiar bureaucratic language applied to extraordinary events creates the double effect Suvin identifies. In his translation of R.U.R., Čapek's own novum—the biological robot as factory-produced labour—is made strange anew for a Maithili readership encountering it for the first time.

### 12.2 Science Fiction as Critical Realism: Fredric Jameson

Fredric Jameson argues in Archaeologies of the Future (2005) that SF's most important function is not prediction but 'the production of what we might call the desire called utopia'—the articulation of what is absent from the present, the 'not-yet.' Viyogi's AI drama Narak Vijay, with its scientist-hero who can navigate between the underworld of crime, the real world of scientific research, and the mythological world of Yamaloka, embodies exactly this utopian imagination: a future in which scientific knowledge and ethical wisdom together might overcome both criminal violence (the kidnappers) and divine judgement (Yamaraja).

Jameson also argues that SF is essentially about 'our incapacity to imagine the future'—which is why it always tells us more about the present than the future. Viyogi's choice of AI and cyborganics as his SF novum in Narak Vijay is acutely 'present'—written in the context of India's rapidly growing AI research sector—and his embedding of this theme within the framework of Hindu cosmology reflects a distinctly Indian anxiety about what traditional moral frameworks (karma, dharma, the judgement of Yamaraja) mean in a world where artificial intelligence may eventually simulate human consciousness.

### 12.3 The Popular Science Essay: Literary Form and Rhetorical Tradition

The popular science essay has a distinguished literary genealogy: Francis Bacon's Essays (1597 onwards), which established the form; Thomas Huxley's essays on evolution (1860s), which demonstrated that rigorous science could be compellingly narrated; J.B.S. Haldane's essays (Possible Worlds, 1927) that pioneered the playful, speculative mode; Richard Feynman's anecdotal science (Surely You're Joking, Mr. Feynman!, 1985); and Carl Sagan's cosmic humanism (Cosmos, 1980; Pale Blue Dot, 1994).

Viyogi's Vigyanak Batkahi belongs to this tradition but with a distinctive vernacular inflection. Unlike Huxley or Sagan writing for a broadly educated English-reading public, Viyogi writes for a community that may have no formal scientific education but has a deep cultural tradition (Sanskrit learning, agricultural knowledge, folklore) that science writing can build upon. His rhetorical strategy—the 'packaging' metaphor, the familiar narrative opening—is not a condescension to his readers but a genuine attempt to bridge two knowledge-worlds that postcolonial education has kept artificially separate.

### 12.4 Translation Theory: Lawrence Venuti and Foreignisation

Lawrence Venuti's influential distinction between 'domestication' (translating to make the foreign text feel native) and 'foreignisation' (preserving

the foreignness of the source text to expand the target reader's horizons) is directly relevant to Viyogi's translation of R.U.R. By choosing to translate Čapek's play rather than adapt it, and by retaining the industrial/corporate setting (Rossum's Universal Robots, the factory island, the mass-production logic), Viyogi opts for foreignisation: he brings the Czech play to Maithili readers in its otherness, refusing to domesticate the Czech industrial capitalism of 1920 into a more familiar Maithili rural setting. This is a politically significant choice—it insists that Maithili readers can and should encounter modernity's global dimensions.

### 12.5 Bakhtin: The Chronotope of the Laboratory

Mikhail Bakhtin's concept of the chronotope—the literary-spatial-temporal configuration through which a genre constructs its world—applies illuminatingly to Viyogi's SF drama. The laboratory (Anupam's 'AI Laboratory (highly confidential)') is the characteristic chronotope of modern SF: a space where time moves differently (experiments run over weeks; discoveries happen in instants), where knowledge is both produced and confined, and where the boundaries between human and non-human are most permeable. In Narak Vijay, this laboratory chronotope is doubled by the mythological chronotope of Yamaloka—the space of judgment and consequence, where all of human time is assessed simultaneously. This double chronotope is distinctly and innovatively Indian.

## XIII. CRITICAL APPRECIATION: INDIAN AESTHETICS AND NĀṬYAŚĀSTRA

### 13.1 Rasa Theory Applied to Science Fiction and Popular Science Writing

Bharata Muni's Nāṭyaśāstra (c. 200 BCE–200 CE) identifies rasa as the essential aesthetic experience of a literary work. While the classical rasas (śṛṅgāra, vīra, karuṇā, raudra, hāsya, bībhatsa, bhayānaka, adbhuta) were developed for drama and poetry, their application to the genres Viyogi practises is illuminating:

**Adbhuta rasa (wonder/marvellous):** The dominant rasa of the Vigyanak Batkahi essays and of Viyogi's SF. The vibhāva (stimulus) is the scientific fact itself—that the universe began in a single point, that atoms have empty space within them, that living tissue can be synthetically produced in a factory. The anubhāva (response) is the reader's wonder. Adbhuta rasa is precisely the aesthetic mode of science—both as practised (the scientist's wonder at nature's complexity) and as communicated (the popular scientist's attempt to transmit that wonder to a general audience). Viyogi explicitly identifies this connection:

he describes scientific research as 'entertaining' because 'you learn something new every day' and the 'mystery and romance' never diminishes.

**Bībhatsa rasa (disgust/uncanny):** Activated in Narak Vijay when the criminal-politicians who are the play's moral villains are described—their nonchalance about killing, their use of scientific knowledge for criminal ends. More subtly, bībhatsa registers in the concept of the robot-as-commodity: the production of biological human-like beings for labour exploitation is, as Čapek recognised, a form of slavery that is obscene precisely because it is concealed behind the neutralising language of technology.

**Raudra rasa (fury):** Present in Viyogi's social critique—both in the popular science essays (the Vigyanak Batkahi preface's quiet fury at the exclusion of Maithili from scientific discourse) and in the drama's indictment of political criminals who corrupt both social and scientific life.

**Hāsya rasa (comic):** The satirical stories of Acta Misiya and the ironic observations of Kichhu Teet Madhur deploy hāsya—the comedy of cultural comparison and intellectual contrast—as both a literary technique and an epistemological tool.

### 13.2 The Nāṭyaśāstra's Mythoscientific Mode in Narak Vijay

Bharata's Nāṭyaśāstra permits the mixing of divine and human characters on stage (the nāṭaka tradition includes both lokadharmi, realistic, and nāṭyadharmi, conventionalised-stylised, modes). Narak Vijay uses both: the scientists and criminals occupy the realistic plane; Narada, Yamaraja, and Chitraguptha occupy the conventionalised mythological plane. This is consistent with the Nāṭyaśāstra's framework, in which the divine and human planes coexist in the theatrical space. Viyogi's innovation is to introduce the third plane of science fiction (the AI laboratory, cyborganics, the digital display board reading 'AI Laboratory (highly confidential)') as a third register that mediates between the human and divine—science as a kind of third cosmos.

### 13.3 Dhvani (Resonance) in the Popular Science Essay

Ānandavardhana's Dhvanyāloka (c. 850 CE) identifies dhvani—the resonant, unstated meaning—as the highest literary achievement. Viyogi's best popular science essays achieve a form of scientific dhvani: what is ostensibly an essay about the Large Hadron Collider resonates with the unstated implication about human curiosity, the desire to know the origins of existence, the cosmological imagination as a form of spiritual aspiration. The essay on AI resonates with the unstated anxiety: what is a human being if a machine can

simulate human thought? This is the dhvani of all serious AI writing, including Čapek's R.U.R.

## XIV. NAVYA-NYĀYA EPISTEMOLOGY OF GAṄGEŚA UPĀDHYĀYA APPLIED TO VIYOGI'S SCIENCE WRITING

### 14.1 Gaṅgeśa and Viyogi: Two Madhubani Intellectuals

Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya (fl. 13th–14th century CE) was, like Viyogi, a native of the Madhubani region of Mithila—the intellectual heartland of the Navya-Nyāya school of Indian logic and epistemology. His Tattvacintāmaṇi ('Wish-Fulfilling Gem of Truth') established the most technically rigorous system of epistemological analysis in Indian philosophy, developing precise tools for analysing pramāṇa (valid knowledge), vyāpti (universal concomitance), and the conditions of valid inference (anumāna). The structural parallel is striking: both are Madhubani-born intellectuals who developed technically precise analytical systems; both worked at the boundary between specialised knowledge and its broader social application.

### 14.2 Viyogi's Science Writing as Pramāṇa-Establishment

Navya-Nyāya identifies four pramāṇas (sources of valid knowledge): pratyakṣa (perception), anumāna (inference), upamāna (analogy/comparison), and śabda (verbal testimony). Viyogi's popular science writing can be analysed as operating through all four to establish valid knowledge for a general Maithili readership:

**Pratyakṣa:** Viyogi grounds his essays in observational facts—the readings of instruments, the results of experiments, the observations of particle detectors. His authority derives partly from the pratyakṣa of the laboratory: he has seen what he reports. In Kichhu Teet Madhur, the travelogue's authority is also pratyakṣa—direct personal observation.

**Anumāna:** The inferential structure is central to popular science writing: from the observed fact (carbon atoms in a rock sample), the physicist infers a general principle (radioactive decay laws), and from that infers an event (the rock was formed 4.5 billion years ago). Viyogi consistently walks his readers through this inferential architecture.

**Upamāna:** Viyogi's characteristic rhetorical strategy is upamāna—analogy. The Maithili reader understands buoyancy through Archimedes's bathtub; understands gravitational attraction through Newton's apple; understands radioactive decay through the analogy of a coin toss. These are not

simplifications but genuine upamānas in the Navya-Nyāya sense: valid cognition through comparative reasoning.

**Śabda:** The authority of scientific testimony (the published results of CERN, the recommendations of WHO and IAEA, the findings of Egyptological research) constitutes the śabda pramāṇa on which Viyogi's essays draw. His careful attribution of sources—Bob Bryer's audio lectures, MIT warnings, WHO guidelines—is an implicit acknowledgement of the śabda dimension of scientific knowledge.

### 14.3 Vyāpti and the Scientific Law

Navya-Nyāya's central logical concept of vyāpti—universal concomitance, the invariable co-occurrence of a property (sādhya) with its sign (liṅga)—is structurally identical to the scientific concept of a natural law: whenever smoke, fire; whenever radioactive decay, the emission of specific radiation; whenever gravitational attraction, the bending of spacetime. Viyogi's popular science writing is, in Navya-Nyāya terms, an extended exercise in establishing vyāptis for a general Maithili audience—teaching them to read nature's signs (liṅgas) as evidence for its laws (vyāptis). This is a remarkable convergence: the founder of Navya-Nyāya and the popular scientist share a fundamental intellectual project, separated by seven centuries.

## XV. THE VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY FRAMEWORK: VIYOGI'S PLACE IN MAITHILI LITERATURE

Gajendra Thakur's Videha (www.videha.co.in)—the first Maithili fortnightly e-journal (ISSN 2229-547X)—has developed what it calls a 'Parallel History of Maithili Literature,' documenting writers excluded from or marginalised by the Sahitya Akademi's conservative Brahmin-dominated advisory structure. Viyogi's position within this framework is distinctive: he is neither a subaltern community writer (like Jagdish Prasad Mandal) nor a caste-politics activist, but an elite scientist whose literary work represents a different kind of 'parallel'—the parallel of interdisciplinary knowledge, of science-literature integration, of global engagement brought back to the vernacular.

The Videha Pothi archive (www.videha.co.in/pothi.htm) includes Viyogi's works, positioning them within a broader project of making Maithili literature representative of all the languages of knowledge, not merely the literary-artistic tradition. Viyogi's Vigyanak Batkahi and his SF drama represent what might be called the 'scientific parallel'—a strand of Maithili literary production that the mainstream Sahitya Akademi establishment has not engaged with precisely because it does not fit the conventional categories of poetry, novel, or drama.

Within the Videha framework, Viyogi is arguably the most important figure for demonstrating that Maithili can be a language of scientific modernity—that it need not be confined to the domains of devotional poetry (Vidyapati's padāvalī), social satire (Harimohan Jha's Khattar Kakak Tarang), or even contemporary social realism (Jagdish Prasad Mandal's Pangu). A language that can discuss the Large Hadron Collider, translate R.U.R., and imagine AI-driven mythological drama is a language of the 21st century.

## XVI. COMPARATIVE STUDY: VIYOGI'S SCIENCE FICTION ACROSS LANGUAGES

### 16.1 Viyogi and Karel Čapek: The Translator-Author Relationship

The most direct comparative relationship in Viyogi's work is with Karel Čapek (1890–1938)—the Czech writer whose R.U.R. he has translated. Čapek shares with Viyogi several structural features: both write about scientific/technological developments with a humanist rather than techno-utopian perspective; both embed social critique within fantastic or scientific frameworks; both were deeply concerned with the ethical implications of technology (Čapek opposed fascism, Čapek's robots represent exploited labour). Čapek's famous statement—'The product of the human brain has escaped the control of human hands. This is the comedy of science'—could serve as the epigraph to Viyogi's Narak Vijay.

### 16.2 Viyogi and Satyajit Ray (Bengali SF)

The most relevant Indian comparison is with Satyajit Ray (1921–1992), whose Professor Shonku series (from 1965, appearing in Sandesh magazine) is the canonical Indian-language SF. Ray's Shonku is an inventor-scientist who creates fantastic gadgets and encounters adventures globally; his SF is fundamentally optimistic about science and tends toward the adbhuta rasa. Viyogi's SF—particularly Narak Vijay—is less sanguine: the AI context is explicitly framed with the MIT warning about existential risk. Where Shonku's science is wonder-generating and benevolent, Viyogi's AI is potentially the 'biggest event in human history' that 'might also be the last.' This reflects a generational shift: Ray wrote in the post-Independence science-optimist mood; Viyogi writes in the age of AI anxiety.

A further contrast: Ray's Shonku operates in the Bengali tradition of kalpabigyan ('science imagination') which the SF critic Adrish Bardhan characterised as encompassing not just SF but 'science fantasy, scientific adventures.' Viyogi's engagement with genre is more precisely calibrated: he labels his works as 'science fiction' and 'artificial intelligence/AI drama' with

explicit awareness of global SF conventions (the R.U.R. connection, the MIT warning). He is, in this sense, more globally genre-conscious than Ray while remaining as deeply vernacular.

### 16.3 Viyogi and Jayant Narlikar (Marathi/English SF)

The closest structural parallel to Viyogi in Indian literature is Jayant Narlikar (b. 1938)—the astrophysicist who writes SF in both Marathi and English (Virus, The Return of Vaman, The Comet, etc.). Like Viyogi, Narlikar brings his scientific expertise directly to bear on his SF: his cosmological knowledge informs his time-travel and alien-contact narratives. Like Viyogi, he writes for a vernacular audience (Marathi) while maintaining global scientific engagement. The key difference: Narlikar is better known internationally (he has an English-language profile) and writes harder SF in the sense of more technically precise scientific content. Viyogi's SF is more culturally hybrid—the mythoscientific mode of Narak Vijay has no equivalent in Narlikar's work.

### 16.4 Viyogi and the Global Golden Age of SF: Asimov, Clarke, Le Guin

The Western SF writers most directly relevant to Viyogi's project are: Isaac Asimov (Foundation, I, Robot), who popularised the idea that a scientist-as-writer could make hard scientific content narratively compelling; Arthur C. Clarke (2001: A Space Odyssey), who explored AI and technological consciousness with philosophical depth; and Ursula K. Le Guin (The Left Hand of Darkness, The Dispossessed), who used SF to explore the social and cultural implications of scientific and technological change.

Viyogi's Narak Vijay most closely resembles Asimov's robot stories in its engagement with AI's ethical dimensions—but departs from Asimov's secular rationalism by embedding AI within Hindu cosmology. This is a fundamental difference: Asimov's robots operate in a post-religious universe governed by rational laws (the Three Laws of Robotics); Viyogi's AI scientist operates in a universe governed simultaneously by rational laws (cyborganics) and by divine judgment (Yamaraja's court). This dual governance reflects the epistemic structure of contemporary India, where scientific modernity and religious-cosmological tradition coexist.

### 16.5 Viyogi and Bengali Robot Fiction: The 'Nobojuger Mohadanob' Tradition

Bengali SF has a specific tradition of robot fiction: Hemendra Kumar Roy's 'Nobojuger Mohadanob' is described as 'the first piece of Bengali literature on robots.' Viyogi's Maithili translation of R.U.R. and his AI drama Narak Vijay place Maithili in conversation with this Bengali tradition while

bringing the globally foundational Čapek text directly into the equation. Maithili SF on robots thus begins not with a derivative adaptation but with a direct translation of the world's seminal robot drama—a more historically grounded starting point than most regional Indian SF can claim.

### 16.6 Viyogi's Popular Science Writing: Comparison with International Tradition

Among Indian language popular science writers, Viyogi's Vigyanak Batkahi is most comparable to Jagdish Chandra Bose's early essays (which constituted the first Indian science fiction, as several historians note) and to the tradition of popular science writing in Bengali established by figures like the ISRO scientist-writers. What makes Viyogi unique is the combination: no other Maithili writer has his scientific credentials (FNA, FNASc, Director of Institute of Physics), and no Indian scientist of his stature has written as extensively and imaginatively in a vernacular language other than Bengali or English.

## XVII. CONCLUSIONS: LITERARY SIGNIFICANCE AND LEGACY

Yogendra Pathak Viyogi's literary significance rests on five achievements of lasting consequence for Maithili literature and for Indian vernacular scientific culture:

**1. Founding of Maithili popular science writing:** Vigyanak Batkahi (Parts 1 & 2) establishes a tradition of scientifically rigorous, literarily accomplished popular science writing in Maithili—a tradition that did not previously exist. For a language whose literary history is measured in over a thousand years (from Vidyapati to the present), the absence of science writing was a significant lacuna. Viyogi fills it.

**2. Founding of Maithili science fiction:** Narak Vijay and Acta Misiya establish Maithili SF as a genre. They do so not by imitating Western SF conventions but by developing a distinctively Indian mythoscientific mode that draws equally on contemporary AI research and Hindu cosmological tradition.

**3. Introducing the world's foundational robot drama to Maithili:** The translation of R.U.R. gives Maithili readers direct access to the play that introduced the word 'robot' to world literature, positioned explicitly within the contemporary AI debate. This is an act of cultural integration—bringing Maithili into the global conversation about technology, labour, and human identity.

**4. The scientist-as-vernacular-intellectual:** Viyogi demonstrates that the highest level of scientific practice (experimental nuclear physics, direction of a

national laboratory, international scientific leadership) is compatible with—and enriched by—deep engagement with vernacular literature. He is, in the Gramscian sense, an organic intellectual of the Indian scientific community.

**5. Scientific humanism in Maithili:** Across all his writings, Viyogi maintains a consistent scientific humanism: a belief that scientific knowledge, properly communicated and ethically deployed, can deepen rather than destroy human culture. His Piramidak Desh Me opens with reincarnation to explain mummification; his Hamar Gaam grounds electrification in the felt experience of village life; his Kichhu Teet Madhur makes the physicist's foreign encounters intelligible through humour and self-deprecation. This is scientific humanism in the truest sense.

From the perspective of Navya-Nyāya epistemology, Viyogi's entire literary project is an exercise in establishing pramāṇas (valid sources of knowledge) for Maithili readers in the domain of modern science—making the pratyakṣa of the laboratory, the anumāna of scientific inference, and the śabda of international scientific consensus available in a language that has previously been confined, as a knowledge-domain, to the humanistic disciplines. This is a philosophical contribution as significant as a new scientific paper, and likely of longer cultural consequence.

*The product of the human brain has escaped the control of human hands. This is the comedy of science.* — Karel Čapek, quoted in Viyogi's Robot (Maithili translation of R.U.R.)

*Success in creating AI would be the biggest event in human history. Unfortunately it might also be the last, unless we learn how to avoid the risks.* — MIT, quoted on the title page of Viyogi's Robot and in Vigyanak Batkahi Part 2

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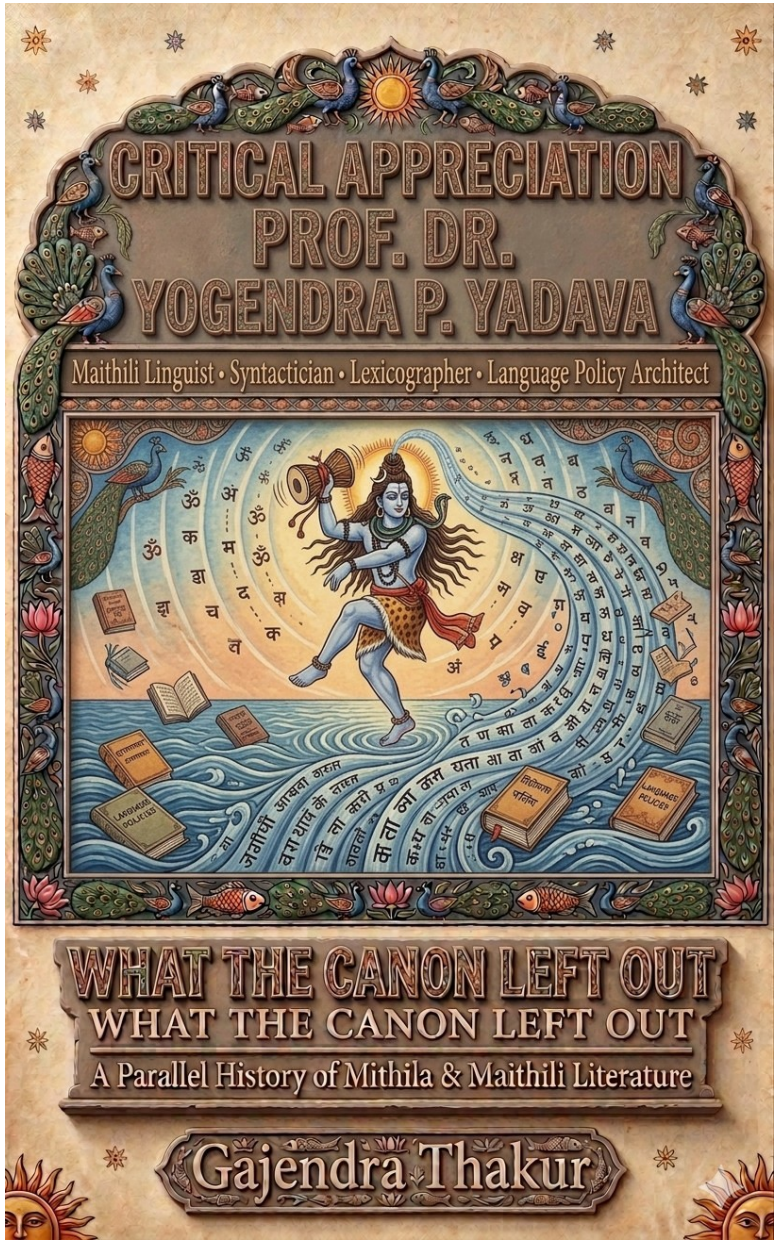
**LESSON 101 · VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY**



# CRITICAL APPRECIATION

**PROF. DR. YOGENDRA P. YADAVA**

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*Indo-Nepalese & Western Literary-Linguistic Theory · Videha Parallel History Framework*

*Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa · Generative Grammar · Sociolinguistics*

## I. BIOGRAPHICAL AND CONTEXTUAL OVERVIEW

### A. Origins and Formation

Prof. Dr. Yogendra Prasad Yadava (प्रो. डॉ. योगेन्द्र प्रसाद यादव) was born in Navarajpur Village, Ward No. 4, District Siraha, State No. 2, Nepal — the heart of the Maithili-speaking Tarai region that straddles the Nepal-India border, the same cultural zone as the ancient kingdom of Mithila. Maithili is his mother tongue, and Nepali and Hindi his acquired second languages, a biographical fact of no small significance: he is a native speaker scholar of a language he spent a lifetime analysing formally, a position that gives him the dual authority of insider knowledge and formal-linguistic rigour.

His educational trajectory reveals a scholar of unusually broad formation. He took his M.A. in English at Tribhuvan University, Kathmandu (1967) — a training in the analytic traditions of English-language literary and linguistic scholarship that would prove foundational. He then proceeded to CIEFL (now EFLU — English and Foreign Languages University), Hyderabad, India, completing a Post-Graduate Diploma in the Teaching of English (1979), an M.Litt. in Linguistics (1980), and his doctorate (1984) on 'Movement Rules in Maithili and English: Their Implications for the Theory of Government and Binding' — the first major application of Chomskyan Government-and-

Binding theory to Maithili syntax. CIEFL Hyderabad in the late 1970s and early 1980s was among the foremost centres of Indian linguistics, and Yadava's doctoral work placed Maithili for the first time within the mainstream of international formal syntactic theory.

After completing his doctorate, Yadava received the Mahendra Vidyabhusana award from the Ministry of Education, His Majesty's Government of Nepal (1985) for his doctoral research — recognition, at the highest governmental level, of the significance of his work for Maithili as a language of national and scholarly importance. He returned to Tribhuvan University's Central Department of Linguistics, where he would build a career spanning over four decades as Professor, Head of Department, and eventually Professor Emeritus.

## B. Postdoctoral Fellowships and International Affiliations

Yadava's postdoctoral career is remarkable for its global reach and the distinction of the institutions that recognised his work. He held a Fulbright Postdoctoral Fellowship at the Department of Linguistics, University of Chicago (1991–1992) — one of the world's premier centres for generative syntax and typological linguistics. He was a Rockefeller Foundation Fellow at the Bellagio Study and Conference Centre, Italy (1993), an External Collaborator in the Projection Typology Project of the German Science Foundation (DFG) at the University of Mainz, Germany (1997) — a centre pivotal to Maithili typological research through the work of Walter Bisang and colleagues — and a Senior Visiting Fellow at the International Institute for Asian Studies (IIAS), Leiden, The Netherlands (1998).

In 2016, he was elected Honorary Life Member of the Linguistic Society of America — the most prestigious recognition in world linguistics, accorded to a small number of non-American scholars of exceptional distinction. This places him in the same company as a handful of South Asian linguists who have received this honour, and confirms his standing as a scholar of global importance.

## C. Institutional Roles

Yadava served as Chief and Head of the Central Department of Linguistics, Tribhuvan University, Kirtipur, Kathmandu, Nepal; as Member of the Academic Council and head of the Department of Mother Tongues, Nepal Academy; as President of the Linguistic Society of Nepal (2000–2004); as Founder Editor of the Journal of Nepalese Studies (Nepal Academy, 1993–1996); as Regional Editor of the Annual Review of South Asian Languages and

Linguistics (Mouton, 2007 onwards); as Regional Editor of The Yearbook of South Asian Languages and Linguistics (Sage, 1998); and as Editor-in-Chief of Nepalese Linguistics (2005–2009). He was Founder Director of the Linguistic Survey of Nepal (2008–2009) and served as Language Advisor to UNMIN (the United Nations Mission in Nepal) in 2007–2008. He supervised ten doctoral students, shaped Nepal's language-in-education policy, and contributed to Nepal's National Language Policy Commission.

### D. Awards and Honours

His awards include: Nepal Prajna Bhasha Puraskar (Nepal Academy Language Award, 2013); Nepal Vidyapati Anusandhan Puraskar (Vidyapati Research Award, Ministry of Culture, Government of Nepal, 2013); Suprabal Jansewashree Medal (Republic Day National Service Medal, 2013, Ministry of Home, Nepal); Itihasshiromani Baburam Acharya Shodhsamman (2012); Mithila Ratna Award at the International Maithili Conference, Kathmandu (2010); Jagadamba-Shree Award 2080 (for continuous contributions to the identification, preservation and study of Nepalese languages); and Shabdayatra Padmakala-Bhimkala Bhasha Samman 2080.

The Mithila Ratna Award (2010) and the Vidyapati Anusandhan Puraskar (2013) are of particular significance for the Videha Parallel History Framework: they situate Yadava not merely as a technical linguist but as a custodian of Mithila's cultural heritage — a scholar whose formal analyses serve the living language community and its history.

## II. SCHOLARLY CORPUS: ANNOTATED CATALOGUE

### A. Doctoral Dissertation

Movement Rules in Maithili and English: Their Implications for the Theory of Government and Binding. Ph.D. Dissertation, CIEFL, Hyderabad, 1983/1984.

This inaugural work is the foundation of Yadava's entire scholarly edifice. Applying Chomsky's Government-and-Binding (GB) framework — which posits that syntactic movement (such as question formation, subject raising, and relativisation) is governed by abstract principles of government, binding, and case assignment — to Maithili, Yadava established that Maithili syntax exhibits

properties that both confirm and complicate universal grammar claims. The dissertation addresses movement rules — operations by which constituents are displaced from their base positions — and analyses how Maithili data illuminates parametric variation in the GB framework. This was the first systematic treatment of Maithili within the generativist paradigm and constituted a landmark in the formal study of Indo-Aryan languages.

## B. Major Books

Issues in Maithili Syntax: A Government-Binding Approach. Munich/Newcastle: Lincom Europa, 1998.

This book-length extension of the doctoral work presents a comprehensive formal-syntactic analysis of Maithili using the Government-and-Binding/Principles-and-Parameters framework. Lincom Europa is the leading European publisher of specialist linguistic monographs, and publication there marked Yadava's work as a contribution to international formal linguistics rather than merely to South Asian area studies. The book analyses agreement morphology, case assignment, non-nominative subjects, anaphor binding, and the structure of Maithili embedded clauses — each a topic of active theoretical debate in the 1990s generativist literature.

Readings in Maithili Language, Literature and Culture (ed.). Kathmandu: Royal Nepal Academy, 1998/1999.

This edited volume of fifteen papers is a foundational reference work for Maithili linguistics in Nepal. It contains Yadava's own 'The Maithili Language and Linguistics: An Overview' (pp. 3–25) — the most comprehensive survey of Maithili linguistics from a Nepalese scholarly perspective — alongside contributions on syntax (U.N. Singh on subjecthood hierarchy), phonology (S.K. Jha on gemination), morphology (R. Bimal on personal pronoun declension), lexicology (G. Jha on euphemism), and literary-cultural topics (R.D. Rakesh on Vidyapati's aesthetics, R.R. Lal on the evolution of Maithili short stories, R. Pandey on Mithila art and history). By gathering Indian and Nepalese Maithili scholars in a single Nepal Academy volume, this collection enacted in institutional form the cross-border linguistic community that Yadava argued for consistently throughout his career.

Prajñā Maithilī-Nepālī-English Dictionary (with Nepali and English Glossaries). Kathmandu: Nepal Academy, 2017.

This trilingual dictionary — Maithili, Nepali, and English — is perhaps Yadava's most socially significant contribution to Maithili as a living language. As a lexicographic resource produced under the Nepal Academy, it serves both the scholarly community and the Maithili-speaking population of Nepal in educational, administrative, and cultural contexts. Dictionaries occupy a special place in the Navya-Nyaya tradition's attention to śabda-pramāṇa (verbal testimony, the authority of words): the dictionary is the institutionalised encoding of śabda-jñāna, the knowledge conveyed through language, and as such it is a foundational epistemic instrument for any language community. Yadava's trilingual dictionary gives Maithili the referential authority that it had long been denied by its institutional marginalisation.

Topics in Nepalese Linguistics (ed. with Warren W. Glover). Kathmandu: Royal Nepal Academy, 1999.

This major co-edited reference volume on Nepalese linguistics as a whole includes Yadava's 'Raising from a Tensed Clause and Linguistic Theory: Evidence from Maithili' — a theoretical article demonstrating that Maithili has a subject-to-subject raising rule from a tensed (finite) clause, a property that distinguishes Maithili-type languages from English-type languages and has significant implications for the universality of binding principles in Universal Grammar.

## C. Key Journal Articles on Maithili

'Face vs. Empathy: The Social Foundation of Maithili Verb Agreement' (with Balthasar Bickel and Walter Bisang). Linguistics, 37.3: 481–518, 1999.

This paper, co-authored with Bickel (now at the University of Zurich) and Bisang (University of Mainz), is Yadava's most internationally cited contribution, appearing in Linguistics — the oldest and most prestigious general linguistics journal. It demonstrates that Maithili has one of the most complex agreement systems of any Indo-Aryan language, with agreement controlled not only by subject but by object, oblique arguments, and even non-arguments. The paper shows that this apparently opaque complexity is not arbitrary but is predicted by two principles governing Maithil social interaction: a principle of social hierarchy ('face' in the sense of Brown and Levinson 1987) and a principle of social solidarity ('empathy' in the sense of Kuno 1987). Crucially, the paper shows that the system is reduced among lower-caste speakers less invested in maintaining the hierarchical style — a finding with

profound sociolinguistic implications for the relationship between language and social structure in Mithila. The paper has been cited over one thousand times.

'A Fresh Look at Grammatical Relations in Indo-Aryan' (with Balthasar Bickel). Lingua 110.5: 343–373, 2000.

This paper, in Lingua, a major typological-linguistic journal, reanalyses the typology of grammatical relations (subject, object, oblique) across Indo-Aryan languages using data from Maithili, proposing that a unified account of Indo-Aryan alignment requires rethinking standard notions of subjecthood and case-marking.

'The Complexity of Maithili Verb Agreement'. In Yearbook of South Asian Languages and Linguistics, ed. Rajendra Singh. Delhi: Sage/De Gruyter Mouton, 1999/2010, pp. 139–152.

A technical companion to the Bickel-Bisang-Yadava paper, documenting in detail the paradigm structure of Maithili verb agreement from a purely grammatical perspective.

'Verb Agreement in Maithili'. Journal of Nepalese Studies 1: 109–121, 1996.

Early systematic treatment of Maithili agreement in a Nepalese linguistics context, providing the empirical foundation for the later collaborative work with Bickel and Bisang.

'The Syntax of Possessor Prominence in Maithili' (with Oliver Bond, Irina Nikolaeva and Sandy Ritchie). In Andras Barany, Oliver Bond and Irina Nikolaeva (eds.), Prominent Internal Possessors. Oxford University Press, 2019, pp. 39–79.

This recent contribution, with Oxford-based typologists, brings Yadava's Maithili research into the cutting edge of 2010s typological syntax, demonstrating that possessors within argument NPs can control verb agreement in Maithili — a phenomenon with implications for theories of syntactic prominence and information structure globally.

'The Maithili Language'. In Jane Garry and Carl Rubino, eds., Facts about the World's Languages: An Encyclopedia of the World's Major Languages, Past and Present. New York: H.W. Wilson Company, 2001, pp. 441–447.

This encyclopaedia entry, in a major international reference work, presents Maithili to a world scholarly audience as a language deserving of serious comparative-linguistic attention, with a concise but rigorous account of its phonology, morphology, syntax, and sociolinguistic status.

### D. Works on Language Policy and Documentation

The Report of the National Language Policy Commission (ed. with Carl Grove, English translation). Kathmandu: Central Department of Linguistics, Tribhuvan University, 2008.

Ethnologue: Languages of Nepal (ed. with John Eppele, M. Paul Lewis and Dan Raj Regmi). Kathmandu: CDL, TU and SIL International, 2012.

Perspectives on Mother Tongue-Based Multilingual Education in Nepal (ed. with Lava Deo Awasthi). Kathmandu: Nepal Academy, 2020.

'Language Use in Nepal'. Population Monograph, Volume 2, pp. 51–72. Kathmandu: CBS and UNFPA, 2014.

These policy and documentation works represent Yadava's sustained commitment to language rights, language endangerment, and the institutional recognition of Nepal's linguistic diversity, including Maithili's position as the second most spoken language in Nepal.

## III. YOGENDRA P. YADAVA AND THE VIDEHA TRADITION

### A. Presence in the Videha Archive

Within the Videha digital archive (ISSN 2229-547X, www.videha.co.in), Yogendra P. Yadava appears as the second interviewee in Munnaji's celebrated series 'हम पुछैत छी' (I Ask / We Ask) — a series of extended interviews with twenty-four major figures of Maithili literature, linguistics, and culture, published across the Videha Sadeha 33 collected edition. This series, listed in Prelim_33 (Videha Sadeha 33), constitutes one of the most significant documentary records of Maithili intellectual life in the digital era, placing

Yadava alongside figures such as Govind Jha, Rajendra Bimal, Ramabhros Kapari 'Bhramar', Taranand Viyogi, Analkant, Becha Thakur, Somdev, Ashok, Jyoti Sunit Chaudhary, Jagdish Prasad Mandal, Rajdev Mandal, Devshankara Navin, and Gajendra Thakur himself.

The placement of Yadava as the second interviewee in this series — after Ravindra Kumar Das — is significant. It signals his recognition within the Videha intellectual community not merely as a technical linguist publishing in international journals, but as a central figure of the Maithili cultural world whose views on language, literature, and society are of importance to the broader Maithili-speaking community. The Videha interview series functions within the Parallel History Framework as a form of oral-documentary history: the recorded testimony of living intellectual practitioners, whose voices the mainstream canonical institutions have not always privileged.

Additionally, Videha 151 (01 April 2014) contains a comprehensive survey of Maithili literature and linguistics in English — a survey that explicitly engages with Yadava's scholarly contributions, particularly his work on verb agreement and Maithili syntax, contextualising it within the broader history of Maithili linguistic scholarship from Grierson onwards. The survey in Videha 151 identifies Yadava as one of the first linguists to assess the implications of movement rules for the theory of Government and Binding as applied to Maithili, a contribution of foundational importance.

## B. The Videha Parallel History Framework and Yadava's Significance

The Videha Parallel History Framework, as constructed by Gajendra Thakur, rests on the conviction that the democratic, pluralist, and institutionally independent Maithili tradition — the tradition that the Sahitya Akademi-centred canon has marginalised — is the true living heritage of Mithila. Within this framework, Yadava occupies a unique position: he is simultaneously a figure of international academic establishment (LSA Honorary Member, Fulbright Fellow, Oxford University Press contributor) and a figure of Nepalese democratic language politics (language policy activist, champion of mother tongue-based multilingual education, defender of Maithili's rights within the Nepalese federal polity).

This dual positioning is itself a structural feature of the Parallel History: the figures most important to Maithili's survival and vitality are not always those most honoured within the narrow canonical literary establishment, but those who serve the language as a living social system. Yadava's advocacy for

Maithili's recognition in Nepalese education — his role in the MLE (Mother Tongue-Based Multilingual Education) policy, his linguistic survey of Nepal, his trilingual dictionary — are acts of language defence that directly parallel, in the political-linguistic domain, what the Videha movement does in the literary domain: insisting on the dignity and validity of Maithili as a full language of culture, scholarship, and public life.

The Videha Parallel History's attention to Nepal-based Maithili scholarship — including Yadava's presence in the Munnaji interview series — reflects a conscious effort to document the transnational character of Maithili linguistic identity. Mithila is politically split between India and Nepal, but the Videha archive insists on treating it as a cultural and linguistic unity. Yadava's career, rooted in Nepal but engaged with Indian, European, and American institutions, embodies this transnational unity.

# IV. CRITICAL ANALYSIS: MAJOR SCHOLARLY CONTRIBUTIONS

## A. Formal Syntax: Government-Binding and the Maithili Parameter

Yadava's doctoral dissertation and the 1998 Lincom Europa monograph constitute the first sustained application of Chomskyan generative syntax to Maithili. Government-and-Binding theory, as formulated by Chomsky in Lectures on Government and Binding (1981) and subsequent work, proposes that syntax is governed by a set of universal principles (such as the Theta Criterion, the Projection Principle, and the Binding Conditions) and a set of parameters — binary switches that account for cross-linguistic variation. The most famous parameter is the pro-drop parameter (whether a language allows subject omission), but GB posits many others relating to case, agreement, and movement.

Yadava's key finding is that Maithili is a 'subject-to-subject raising from tensed clause' language — meaning that the subject of a tensed embedded clause can be raised to become the subject of the matrix clause, a property that apparently violates the binding principle for anaphors (anaphors must be bound in their governing category). He resolves this apparent violation by arguing that INFL (Inflection) in Maithili is generated inside V and does not govern the subject DP, so the 'governing category' for binding purposes is different from English.

This analysis has implications for the universality of the binding conditions and for our understanding of cross-linguistic variation in the syntax of raising constructions.

From the perspective of Indian linguistic theory, this formal-generativist analysis can be read as a sophisticated modern equivalent of Panini's ashtadhyayi: a grammar of grammar, an attempt to identify the minimal set of rules (or parameters) that generate all and only the grammatical sentences of a language. Panini's method — economy, formal precision, abstract rules governing surface phenomena — is structurally analogous to the GB programme, and Yadava's work thus occupies a position within a continuous tradition of formal language analysis stretching from Panini through the Western medieval grammarians to the generativists.

## B. Verb Agreement, Social Hierarchy, and Face Theory

The 1999 Linguistics paper (with Bickel and Bisang) on 'Face vs. Empathy' is the work for which Yadava is most internationally known, and it represents the most successful integration of formal-grammatical and sociolinguistic analysis in Maithili scholarship. The paper demonstrates that Maithili's agreement system — which cross-references subject, object, oblique arguments, and possessors, encoding person, honorific degree, gender, spatial distance, and focus in a paradigm of considerable complexity — is not morphological noise but the grammatical encoding of a specific social ontology.

The key insight is that the paradigm structure of Maithili agreement can be derived from two social principles: (1) a principle of social hierarchy, based on Brown and Levinson's (1987) theory of face — the preservation of 'positive face' (desire for social approval) and 'negative face' (desire for autonomy) — which predicts the honorific dimension of agreement; and (2) a principle of social solidarity, based on Kuno's (1987) concept of empathy — the speaker's degree of identification with different participants — which predicts the patterns of neutralisation and non-neutralisation in third-person agreement.

From a Navya-Nyaya perspective, this analysis is a sophisticated exercise in vyāpti-nirṇaya (the determination of universal concomitance): the paper identifies the invariant relationship (vyāpti) between social-structural properties (the social hierarchy and empathy principles) and grammatical properties (the specific shape of the agreement paradigm), and demonstrates that this vyāpti holds universally within the Maithili speech community. The paper also makes an important claim about the epistemological status of social knowledge: speakers of Maithili must possess continuous, detailed knowledge

of the social hierarchy and their degrees of empathy with all interlocutors in order to produce grammatical utterances — meaning that social knowledge is not merely pragmatic but grammatically obligatory. In Navya-Nyaya terms, this social knowledge constitutes a form of pratyaksha (direct perception) of the social world, which is systematically encoded in the language.

The paper's finding that lower-caste speakers reduce the agreement system is also of major significance for the Videha Parallel History Framework. It shows that the complex honorific agreement system — which encodes the hierarchical social structure of Maithil Brahmin-centred society — is not a universal feature of Maithili but a feature of the socially dominant variety. Non-dominant speakers, particularly those positioned outside or below the hierarchical system, use a reduced system. This is entirely consistent with the Videha framework's insistence on the democratic plurality of Maithili linguistic practice against the hegemony of a single 'standard' or 'prestige' variety.

## C. Raising from Tensed Clauses: A Typological Argument

The 1999 paper 'Raising from a Tensed Clause and Linguistic Theory: Evidence from Maithili' addresses one of the most contested issues in 1990s generative syntax: whether raising (the movement of a subject from embedded to matrix position) can apply from a tensed (finite) embedded clause. In English, raising applies only from tenseless (infinitival) clauses; tensed clause subjects cannot be raised. Yadava demonstrates that in Maithili, raising from tensed clauses is possible, instantiated by a movement rule functionally analogous to English subject-to-subject raising but parametrically distinct.

This finding situates Maithili as a 'Maithili-type' language, contrasted with 'English-type' languages, in Chomsky's parametric framework. The identification of a systematic parametric difference based on Maithili data is a contribution to linguistic typology of the first order, comparable to the identification of pro-drop languages (Italian, Spanish) or scrambling languages (Japanese, German) as distinct parametric types. It demonstrates that Maithili is not a peripheral or exotic language but a central data point for universal grammar theory.

## D. Syntax of Possessor Prominence

The 2019 Oxford University Press contribution (with Bond, Nikolaeva and Ritchie) demonstrates that Maithili allows possessors within argument NPs to control verb agreement — a phenomenon called 'possessor raising' or 'possessor agreement' that is typologically rare and theoretically challenging.

The paper analyses this within a modern constraint-based syntactic framework, arguing that possessor prominence in Maithili reflects the language's more general tendency to maximise the range of arguments that can control agreement. This work continues the tradition of the 1999 Bickel-Bisang-Yadava paper by further documenting the exceptional structural richness of Maithili's agreement system and its implications for universal grammar.

### E. Lexicography and Language Documentation

Yadava's contribution to Maithili lexicography, most fully realised in the 2017 Prajñā Maithilī-Nepālī-English Dictionary, is grounded in an understanding of lexicography as a fundamental act of language preservation and empowerment. In a multilingual context where Maithili competes with Nepali and Hindi for domains of official use, a rigorous trilingual dictionary serves multiple functions: it stabilises Maithili vocabulary; it enables translation between the language communities of Nepal; it provides the definitional resources necessary for Maithili's use in education, law, and administration; and it asserts Maithili's equivalence with the prestige languages of the region.

As co-editor of the Ethnologue: Languages of Nepal (2012) — the first comprehensive documentation of all languages spoken in Nepal — Yadava also contributed to the global mapping of Nepal's linguistic diversity, ensuring that endangered and minority languages received the same scholarly documentation as major ones.

## V. THEORETICAL FRAMEWORKS: A SYSTEMATIC ASSESSMENT

### A. Saussurean Structuralism

Ferdinand de Saussure's foundational distinction between langue (the abstract system of a language) and parole (individual speech acts) provides the theoretical backdrop against which Yadava's formal-syntactic work operates. Yadava's analyses consistently address langue — the abstract grammatical system — rather than parole, consistent with the Chomskyan programme's focus on the 'ideal speaker-listener's' knowledge of the grammar. However, the 1999 Bickel-Bisang-Yadava paper significantly complicates this distinction by showing that the langue of Maithili — specifically its agreement system — is itself constituted by social practices that belong to the parole domain. Social

interaction (face and empathy) is not merely contextual noise but is systematically encoded in the abstract grammar.

## B. Chomskyan Generative Grammar

Yadava's formal work operates squarely within the Chomskyan programme, progressing from Government-and-Binding theory (dissertation, 1983; Lincom Europa monograph, 1998) through Minimalism (later work on possessor prominence). The core of the Chomskyan programme — that human language is a specific biological faculty (the Language Acquisition Device) generating an infinite number of sentences from a finite set of rules, with universal principles and language-specific parameters — provides the theoretical context within which Yadava's Maithili data consistently proves significant. Each parametric finding about Maithili (raising from tensed clauses, the structure of agreement, possessor prominence) contributes a data point to the cross-linguistic picture of parametric variation.

## C. Typological Linguistics

Through his collaborations with Bickel, Bisang, Bond, Nikolaeva and others, Yadava contributes to typological linguistics — the cross-linguistic study of structural diversity and universals. The typological significance of Maithili's agreement system, its raising properties, and its possessor syntax extends beyond South Asia to the global comparative study of language. Yadava's work places Maithili in typological databases (WALS — the World Atlas of Language Structures — cites Maithili data), making it a reference point for researchers working on agreement, case, and grammatical relations in any language.

## D. Sociolinguistics

Through the face-empathy paper and his language policy work, Yadava contributes to sociolinguistics — the study of the relationship between language and society. His demonstration that Maithili verb agreement encodes social hierarchy and solidarity is a contribution to the sociolinguistic tradition of Labov (social stratification of language variation), Brown and Levinson (face theory), and Goffman (social interaction and performance). His language policy work — on multilingual education, language rights, language endangerment — engages with the sociolinguistic tradition of Fishman (language maintenance and shift), Phillipson (linguistic imperialism), and Skutnabb-Kangas (linguistic human rights).

## E. Navya-Nyāya Epistemology of Gaṅgeśa

The application of Navya-Nyāya epistemological tools to Yadava's linguistic work requires a step of theoretical translation that is itself illuminating. Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's Tattvacintāmaṇi (c. 1325 CE, Mithila) — the foundational text of the Navya-Nyāya school — analyses the four sources of valid knowledge (pramāṇa): pratyaksha (direct perception), anumāna (inference), upamāna (analogy/comparison), and śabda (verbal testimony). Gaṅgeśa's elaboration of these categories, particularly his analysis of anumāna through the concept of vyāpti (universal concomitance), provides a framework for evaluating the epistemological status of linguistic knowledge.

In Yadava's work, three Navya-Nyāya categories are directly relevant. First, śabda-pramāṇa (the authority of language/testimony): Yadava's lexicographic work — the Maithili-Nepali-English dictionary, the Readings in Maithili — is precisely the institutionalisation of śabda-jñāna, encoding the established meanings of Maithili words in a form that can transmit valid knowledge across contexts. The dictionary is the formal embodiment of śabda-pramāṇa for a speech community.

Second, anumāna (inference through vyāpti): the face-empathy paper's core argument is an anumāna — an inference from observed patterns (the distribution of agreement markers) to a general principle (the social hierarchy and empathy rules) via the identification of a vyāpti (invariant concomitance between social-structural facts and grammatical facts). The paper's method — identifying the necessary and sufficient conditions under which specific agreement markers appear — is structurally parallel to Navya-Nyāya's analysis of inferential cognition through the discrimination of hetu (reason) and sādhya (property to be proved) connected by vyāpti.

Third, pratyaksha (direct perception): Yadava's mother-tongue status as a Maithili speaker gives him access to a form of native-speaker pratyaksha — direct intuitive knowledge of grammaticality — that is unavailable to non-native scholars of Maithili. This epistemic privilege, in the Navya-Nyāya framework, constitutes a superior form of pramāṇa for claims about Maithili grammar: the native speaker's grammaticality judgements are a form of savikalpa-pratyaksha (determinate perception) that grounds the formal analysis. Gaṅgeśa's insistence on the reliability of perceptual cognition under the appropriate conditions maps directly onto the modern generativist's reliance on native-speaker intuitions as data.

There is a deeper connection between Navya-Nyāya and Yadava's work, rooted in geography. Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya was himself a Maithil — born in Karion, Darbhanga, the heart of Mithila — writing in Sanskrit in the fourteenth century about the nature of valid knowledge, including knowledge conveyed through language (śabda). Yadava, a Maithil writing in English six centuries later about the formal structure of the same language that Gaṅgeśa spoke natively, continues a tradition of rigorous formal analysis of language rooted in the Mithila intellectual heritage. The Navya-Nyāya school's centuries-long engagement with the epistemology of śabda (language as a knowledge source) and the formal analysis of vākya (sentence structure) is the ancient predecessor of the modern formal-linguistic enterprise that Yadava represents.

## F. Indian Alaṃkāra Tradition and Comparative Literary Linguistics

As editor of Readings in Maithili Language, Literature and Culture (1999), Yadava bridges the purely linguistic and the literary-cultural. The volume includes essays on Vidyapati's aesthetics and the evolution of Maithili short stories, situating linguistic scholarship within the broader tradition of Maithili literary culture. The Sanskrit alaṃkāra tradition — with its analysis of śabda-śakti (the power of words), dhvani (suggestion/resonance), and vakrokti (oblique expression) — is relevant here: a language's formal structure (as analysed by Yadava) and its literary potential (as explored by Vidyapati and his successors) are inseparable, since the same grammatical properties — the complex agreement system, the honorific distinctions, the syntactic flexibility — that make Maithili technically interesting also make it aesthetically distinctive.

The face-empathy paper's analysis of how Maithili agreement encodes social hierarchy can be read, from an alaṃkāra perspective, as an analysis of the social rasa of Maithili utterances: the agreement morphology signals not just grammatical relations but the emotional-social register of the interaction, its degree of formality, respect, intimacy, and distance. The honorific system that Yadava analyses is, in literary terms, a system for encoding śṛṅgāra-rasa (erotic/intimate register), vīra-rasa (heroic/formal register), and other rasa-distinctions in the grammatical structure of every sentence.

# VI. THE VIDEHA PARALLEL HISTORY FRAMEWORK: CRITICAL ASSESSMENT

## A. Yadava as a Parallel History Figure

Within the Videha Parallel History Framework's project of recovering the democratic, pluralist, and institutionally independent Maithili tradition, Yogendra P. Yadava represents a specific and important type: the transnational Maithil intellectual whose work serves the language community without being institutionally beholden to either the Indian Sahitya Akademi or the Nepalese state cultural apparatus. His base at Tribhuvan University gives him institutional independence from the Bihar-centred Indian Maithili establishment; his postdoctoral work at Chicago, Leiden, Mainz, and Bellagio gives him intellectual independence from any single national tradition; and his advocacy for multilingual education and language rights situates him squarely within a democratic language politics that the Videha Parallel History endorses.

Yadava's Mithila Ratna Award (2010) — given at an International Maithili Conference — and his Vidyapati Anusandhan Puraskar (2013) from the Nepalese Ministry of Culture are markers of recognition by the transnational Maithili community itself, rather than by the narrow canonical establishment. The Videha Parallel History, which consistently honours figures recognised by the community rather than by the institution, finds in Yadava an exemplary figure.

## B. Language Rights as Parallel Literary Politics

Yadava's sustained advocacy for Maithili's rights within Nepal — his role in the MLE policy, the Linguistic Survey of Nepal, the national language policy commission, the trilingual dictionary — is the political-linguistic equivalent of what the Videha literary movement does in the aesthetic domain. Both assert the dignity and validity of Maithili against the hegemonic pressure of dominant languages (Nepali in Nepal, Hindi in India) and canonical literary establishments. Yadava's argument that Maithili's 12% share of Nepal's population entitles it to full recognition in education, administration, and public life is structurally parallel to Videha's argument that the democratic, non-canonical Maithili literary tradition is entitled to the same scholarly recognition as the Sahitya Akademi canon.

The Videha Parallel History Framework's attention to cross-border Maithili — treating the language as a cultural unity that transcends the India-Nepal border

— is directly supported by Yadava's scholarly agenda. His paper 'Cross-border Languages Shared by Nepal and India' (2011), his documentation of Maithili in the Nepal census, and his collaborative work with Indian Maithili scholars in the Readings volume all enact the transnational linguistic community that the Videha framework asserts.

### C. Greyersonian Legacy and its Critique

Sir George Abraham Grierson's Linguistic Survey of India (1903–1928) provides the colonial-era framework within which Maithili was first formally documented. Grierson's grammar and cresthomathy of Maithili (available on Videha's pothi.htm) remain foundational references. Yadava's Linguistic Survey of Nepal (2008–2009) — of which he was Founder Director — is explicitly a post-colonial updating and indigenisation of the Greyersonian project: it applies modern sociolinguistic methods, democratic principles of community participation, and post-colonial sensitivity to language rights to the documentation of Nepal's languages, including Maithili. This positions Yadava's work as both heir to and critic of the colonial-era documentation tradition, a position entirely consistent with the Videha Parallel History's project of recovering language history on its own terms.

## VII. WESTERN CRITICAL FRAMEWORKS

### A. Bourdieu: Linguistic Capital and Field Theory

Pierre Bourdieu's theory of linguistic capital (Language and Symbolic Power, 1991) analyses language as a form of capital that confers social power on its speakers. In multilingual contexts, the relative value of languages as capital is determined by the power of the markets in which they are deployed: a language that is valued in the educational and administrative market commands higher capital than one that is confined to the domestic domain. Yadava's entire career — from the formal syntactic analysis that asserts Maithili's place in international linguistics to the language policy advocacy that seeks to extend Maithili's market value in Nepalese education — is a sustained effort to increase Maithili's linguistic capital, to validate it as a language of intellectual and official prestige alongside Nepali and Hindi.

The face-empathy paper can be read through Bourdieu as a demonstration that Maithili speakers possess an unusually refined and complex form of linguistic

capital: the mastery of the honorific agreement system constitutes a form of symbolic capital within Maithil society, signalling social competence and cultural knowledge. The reduction of this system by lower-caste speakers, documented in the paper, illustrates Bourdieu's point that linguistic capital is unequally distributed along social hierarchies — and that those positioned outside the dominant culture may resist or simplify its most elaborate linguistic forms.

## B. Joshua Fishman: Language Maintenance and Shift

Joshua Fishman's theoretical framework for understanding language maintenance and shift (Reversing Language Shift, 1991) provides a sociolinguistic context for Yadava's language policy work. Fishman's GIDS scale (Graded Intergenerational Disruption Scale) measures the degree to which a minority language is threatened by the dominant language in terms of intergenerational transmission. Yadava's documentation of Maithili in the Nepal census and his advocacy for mother tongue-based multilingual education are explicitly concerned with reversing the shift from Maithili to Nepali that census data consistently shows in the younger population. His work on MLE (mother tongue-based multilingual education) is a direct application of Fishman's insights: the surest way to maintain a minority language is to use it as a medium of education in the early years of schooling.

## C. Skutnabb-Kangas: Linguistic Human Rights

Yadava's 2023 chapter in The Handbook of Linguistic Human Rights (Wiley, with Awasthi and Turin) engages explicitly with Tove Skutnabb-Kangas's framework of linguistic human rights — the argument that all children have a right to education in their mother tongue, and that denial of this right constitutes a form of 'linguistic genocide' (the destruction of a language through institutional suppression). Yadava's career-long advocacy for Maithili in Nepalese education is a practical application of this framework, and his academic engagement with the LHR tradition places him within the most progressive current of contemporary sociolinguistics.

## D. Derrida, Bhartrihari, and the Philosophy of Language

The Videha 396 editorial (which analyses the Ramawatar Yadav Visheshank but whose theoretical framework applies equally to Yadava's scholarship) engages with the philosophy of language in terms of the Grammarian tradition (Bhartrihari's śabda-brahman, the doctrine that language is the ultimate reality)

and its relationship to contemporary Western philosophy of language (Derrida, deconstruction). Bhartrihari's Vākyapadīya analyses language in terms of the four levels of vāk (para, paśyantī, madhyamā, vaikharī — from transcendent unity to articulated speech), a framework that anticipates the modern distinction between underlying and surface structure. Yadava's formal syntactic work — which posits abstract underlying structures (D-structure, or in more recent terms, the base-generated phrase structure) that are transformed into surface forms by movement rules — is structurally parallel to Bhartrihari's analysis, though developed independently within the Western generativist tradition.

# VIII. CRITICAL SYNTHESIS: STRENGTHS, LIMITATIONS, LEGACY

## A. Strengths

Yadava's principal strengths are, first, his capacity to synthesise formal-grammatical rigour with sociolinguistic depth: the face-empathy paper is the supreme example, demonstrating that the most technical features of Maithili morphosyntax are inseparable from the social structure of Maithil society. This integration of formal and social analysis is rare in linguistics and gives his work a reach and significance beyond purely technical circles.

Second, his transnational perspective. By working at the intersection of the Nepalese, Indian, and international scholarly communities, Yadava prevents Maithili from being confined to regional or area-studies frameworks. Maithili data appears in Linguistics, Lingua, Himalayan Linguistics, and Oxford University Press volumes alongside data from European, African, and East Asian languages, asserting Maithili's equivalence as a reference language for universal grammar theory.

Third, his commitment to language rights and documentation. The Linguistic Survey of Nepal, the multilingual dictionary, the MLE policy advocacy — these constitute a sustained and coherent effort to serve the Maithili-speaking community, not merely to analyse it from outside.

## B. Limitations and Open Questions

Yadava's formal-syntactic work, while foundational, is almost entirely in English and addressed to an international academic audience. Its accessibility to the Maithili-speaking community itself — to the poets, writers, and cultural practitioners of the Videha tradition — is necessarily limited. The 1999 Readings volume partially addresses this by including literary-cultural essays alongside linguistic ones, but the monograph and major journal articles remain within the technical-linguistic register.

A further question concerns the relationship between Yadava's analysis of the honorific agreement system as a feature of Maithil social structure and the Videha Parallel History's critique of that same social structure as hierarchical and exclusionary. If the complex honorific agreement system is — as Yadava's paper shows — a grammatical encoding of the Brahmin-centric social hierarchy of Mithila, its analysis and documentation (however brilliant) is simultaneously a documentation of social inequality. The fact that lower-caste speakers reduce the system is not merely a linguistic curiosity but a sociolinguistic act of resistance — and the question of whose grammar Yadava's formal analysis ultimately describes (the prestige variety? the full range of Maithili varieties?) is one that the Videha Parallel History Framework would wish to press more firmly.

## C. Legacy

Prof. Yogendra P. Yadava's legacy in Maithili linguistics is threefold. He is the founder of formal generative Maithili syntax, the scholar who placed Maithili firmly on the international typological map through the face-empathy paper and his collaborations with Bickel, Bisang, Bond and Nikolaeva, and the architect of Nepal's language documentation and rights framework for Maithili and other indigenous languages. He has been cited over a thousand times in international scholarship and honoured by the Linguistic Society of America, the Government of Nepal, and the Maithili community itself. His Prajñā Dictionary and the Linguistic Survey of Nepal will serve the Maithili community for generations. And his presence in the Videha Munnaji interview series ensures that his voice — the voice of the native-speaker scholar, the transnational Maithil intellectual — is part of the digital archive of Maithili culture that the Videha Parallel History is building for the future.

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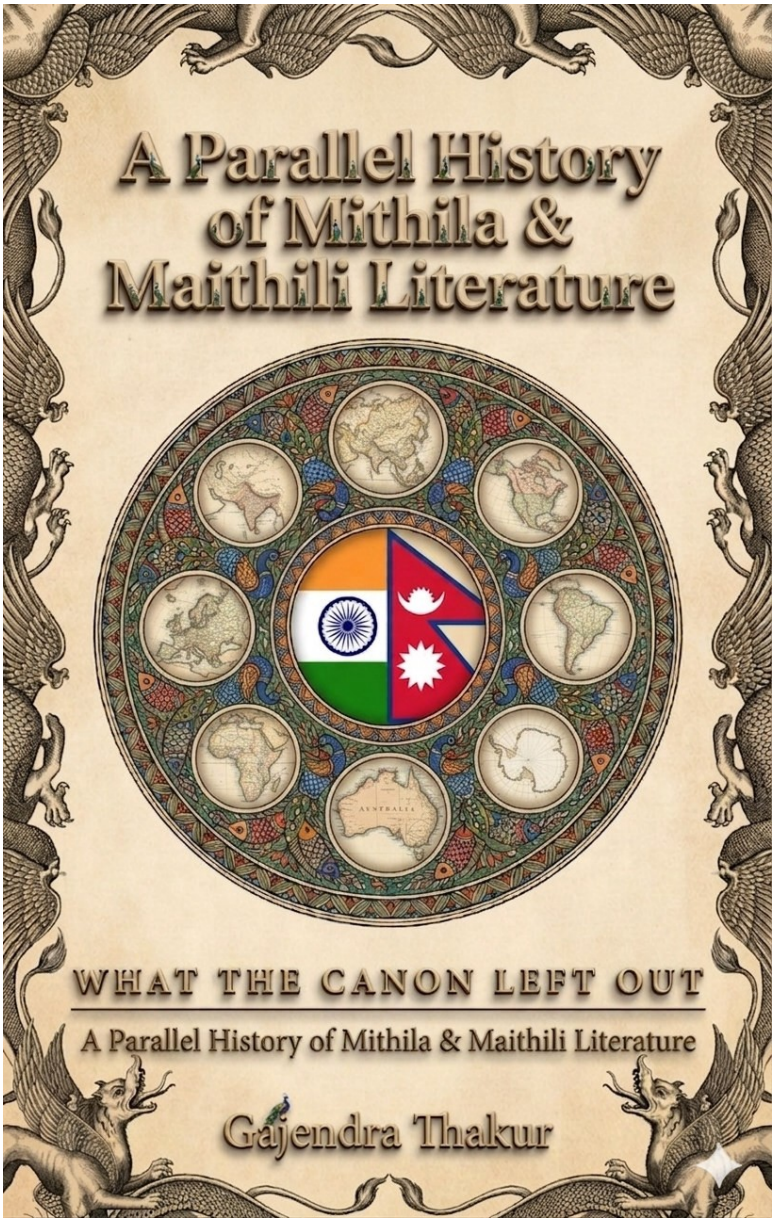
## APPENDIX: METHODOLOGICAL NOTE

The Nepal Bikram Samvat years cited have been converted to approximate CE years using the standard offset of BS minus 56–57 years. Web sources consulted include the Videha digital archive (videha.co.in). All URLs were last accessed April 2026. This research was prepared using primary texts, and standard academic resources. All quoted material is from the cited sources. For the most current scholarship, consult the Videha Parallel History series at www.videha.co.in/gajenthakur.htm.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ABOUT THE AUTHOR

GAJENDRA THAKUR — Maithili author, editor, and literary scholar — founder of the Videha Parallel Literary Movement and founded the Videha eJournal in 2000 and has edited it without interruption since. He writes in Maithilī, Hindi, Sanskrit, and English, and has authored scholarly monographs on Gaṅgeśa Upādhyāya's Navya-Nyāya and the parallel history of Mithilā's literary cultures.

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